Stargate Etheria

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Teen And Up Audiences

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Stargate Etheria

by Starfox5

Summary

Entering a gate leading to an unknown planet while dodging fire wasn't too uncommon for SG-1. Meeting strange new people wasn't unusual either for the Best Friends Squad. But figuring out how to deal with each other, the remnants of the Horde Clones and the Goa'uld threat without a D.H.D. for the Stargate on Etheria? That was new for both.

Notes

Disclaimer: I do not own She-Ra and the Princesses of Power or any of the characters in the series. I do not own Stargate: SG-1 or any of the characters in the series.
Author's Notes: This story is set in an Alternate Universe. While the canon events in She-Ra and SG-1 up to this point happened, there will be changes to either series' background to fit them into the same universe.

The Encounter

Trias, July 10th, 1998

“Take cover!” Jack O’Neill yelled as he jumped behind a large rock, two blasts from Jaffa staff weapons narrowly missing him and blowing up a tree behind him. Another exploration mission gone awry. Sometimes, he wondered if they were cursed with how often they ended up on a planet full of enemies.

He ignored the wooden splinters raining down on him and glanced around. The rest of his team had taken cover - he could see Daniel just crawling behind the remnants of a wall while Carter and Teal'c were already returning fire from behind two rocks further back.

Good. He speed-crawled along the rock, then peered around the other end. Another shot from a staff weapon hit the rock, showering the area with stone splinters while he pulled back.

No way to flank the enemy on this side - the staff weapons were notoriously unprecise, but with the blast radius from a hit… He took a deep breath, bent around the corner, leading with his M4A1 carbine and fired two bursts before pulling back again.

Three more blasts hit the rock, throwing up dirt at its edge. There had to be at least two dozen Jaffa out there, to focus on him with three while the others were still pinned down. He checked on the rest. Carter, as expected, was returning fire while changing positions with textbook perfection. Teal'c had shifted behind a larger rock and kept their left flank clear. And Daniel… was pointing his zat’nik’tel vaguely into the direction of the enemy and squeezing off shots.

“Daniel!” Jack yelled. “Fall back and dial us out! Carter, Teal'c - cover him!”

To his credit, Daniel didn’t argue and started crawling back towards the Stargate behind them. He was even using the rocks on the way as cover.

Jack took a deep breath, then stood, leaning against the rock as he fired a long burst into the treeline from which the Jaffa were

shooting at them. This time, the top of the rock disintegrated under the fire from half a dozen staff weapons an instant after he dropped to the ground.

“Must have hit someone,” he muttered, baring his teeth as he crawled away. Smoke from all the explosions was covering the area but that wouldn’t last forever. Just long enough.

Jack jumped up and sprinted back and to the right, sliding behind a smaller rock and into a firing position. The smoke was still clearing when he spotted two Jaffa charging their position - they were using the smoke to hide from Carter and Teal'c.

He dropped the first with two bursts from his carbine, but the second threw himself to the ground and rolled into a ditch before Jack could shoot him as well.

Those were skilled Jaffa. Not Apophis’s, according to Teal'c. Well, they could sort out who they had fought once they were back at Stargate Command. Jack glanced behind him. Daniel had almost reached the D.H.D. Good.

He popped up from cover to fire another burst at the Jaffa in the treeline and tried to keep an eye on the Jaffa in the ditch. If that guy made it into their position…

More blasts forced him to reposition again, behind an even smaller rock. “We’re running out of rocks!” he yelled. “Hurry, Daniel!”

“I am, Jack!” Daniel yelled back. He had almost reached the D.H.D.

Jack grinned and emptied his magazine into the treeline to keep the Jaffa’s heads down. Daniel would need a few seconds to…

Movement near his old position caught his attention as he pulled back to reload. The hiding Jaffa! He had a clear line of fire to Daniel! And Jack was out of ammo!

“Daniel! Watch out!” he screamed as he swapped magazines and jumped up again, lining up his shot, firing as he aimed, anything to make the bastard flinch and miss…

His bullets caught the Jaffa a moment too late - Jack saw the staff fire. Heard Daniel scream. “Daniel! Carter!” She was closest!

“I’m… I’m OK! But he hit the D.H.D.!” Daniel yelled back.

What? With it, they couldn’t dial the Stargate. Couldn’t return to Earth. Would be captured here - there had to be more Jaffa approaching. Gliders on the way. He fired into the treeline again. Perhaps he should save a bullet for himself...

“Sir! It’s dialling!” Carter yelled. “Outgoing!”

“What?”

“The Stargate is dialling!”

“But I didn’t enter the coordinates! And the D.H.D. is damaged!” Daniel complained.

Jack slid back into cover to swap magazines again. Three left. And about two dozen Jaffa. No choice. “Get through the gate!” he yelled. “Hurry!”

“But Jack!”

“Into the gate, Daniel!” Carter yelled, already sprinting towards the archaeologist and the gate - she knew what the alternative was. Better dead than snaked.

“Teal'c! I’ll cover you!”

The big guy didn’t argue either - just fell back, firing on the move, then stopped behind a rock to cover Jack just as Carter pushed Daniel through the gate.

Jack started to run, bent over to reduce his profile. Staff bursts went past him left and right, blowing up rock and dirt. Splinters tugged at his cap and pinged against his vest.

“Go on!” Teal'c snapped as Jack passed him.

“Like hell!” Jack muttered, crouching down next to the gate and aiming his carbine at the enemy. “Fall back!”

Teal'c obeyed, running faster than a man his size had any right to, and jumped through the gate.

Jack emptied his magazine as he moved backwards up the ramp, more blasts missing him, then one blast that was a little too close all but blew him through the gate.

He came out rolling over his shoulder, down a ramp, his carbine flying away. It was a steeper ramp than expected, he realised as the gate went out behind him. He came to a stop on his back - and found himself staring up in the face of a huge cat. A huge *alien* cat.

*****

Whispering Woods, Etheria, Same Day.

“I think there’s a passage here,” Adora said, leaning forward to study the wall in front of her. The light from her lamp wasn’t the best.

“You thought that before. And we spent half an hour digging through stone and rock to discover… more rock,” Catra said behind her.

Adora glanced over her shoulder. Her girlfriend - even after months, she still had to suppress a silly grin every time she thought that - was leaning against the wall, hands behind her head and rolling her eyes. She could see perfectly well here, of course. At her feet, Melog was acting as if it was cleaning its

mane. “I don’t remember you doing much digging,” Adora told Catra.

“Someone had to keep an eye out for dangers,” Catra replied. “This is a lost outpost of the First Ones, in the middle of the Whispering Woods. So, we have to expect both some monsters the First Ones created and forgot to dispose of and the general garden variety of monsters from those cursed woods who took up residence here. And I’ve got the best eyes and ears of us all, which makes me the natural choice for lookout.”

“And you don’t like digging,” Adora added.

“And I don’t like digging.” Catra flashed her a toothy grin that made Adora think of... other things.

“Or working,” Glimmer muttered as she walked up to them. “Entrapta finished examining the remains of the console in the main room. The memory crystals were smashed, she said.”

Adora knew Catra had heard the dig against her, but her girlfriend didn’t react other than looking away and clenching her teeth - Adora could see her jaw muscles move. She wanted to sigh. If Catra didn’t give as good as she got against Glimmer, it usually meant she was feeling down. Perhaps Adora shouldn’t have asked her to come with them on this expedition. No. They were a couple, and she wanted Catra and the others to not only get along but be comfortable with each other. And Glimmer didn’t mean to be mean. She was just a little cranky now.

“Yes, Entrapta’s trying to recover some data, but I don’t think she’ll find anything intact enough for a partial retrieval.” Bow joined them, ducking under a root that had managed to burrow through the ceiling. “Another dead end?”

“No!” Adora said. “I’m sure there’s a tunnel behind this wall. And yes, I’m really sure this time.” She pointed at the symbol on the wall. “This means ‘Gate’. And this is a wall, not bedrock. So, this is a gate.”

“Or some First One flunky made a mistake,” Catra pointed out. “Or this was planned to be a gate, but they never got around to dig it out.” She crossed her arms over her chest. “If you want to spend another half an hour digging through rock, be my guest, though.”

Glimmer bared her teeth in return. “I’ve got a better plan: We just dig a small hole, so we can check if there’s anything behind this wall.”

“We would need a drill for that,” Bow objected.

“No, we just need She-Ra!” Glimmer beamed at her, Adora realised.

“Me?”

“You can drive your sword through the wall. Wriggle a little to widen it, lather rinse repeat, and we have a hole!” Glimmer said.

“Or you could alter your sword and turn it into a drill,” Bow suggested.

That sounded… well, either way, Adora would be digging a hole.

Catra snickered. “Poor She-Ra. From Champion of Etheria to convenient excavation tool.”

Adora stuck her tongue out at her in return. She wasn’t mad - it was good to see Catra smile. Then she raised her hand and closed her eyes. “For the Honour of Grayskull!”

As always, power filled her as she changed. Grew. Became far more than she was. Power that made her feel as if she could do anything. She barely noticed her clothes and hairstyle change as she became She-Ra. Princess of Power.

“Nice light show. Now, get to it, slacker,” Catra commented. Adora frowned at her - she wasn’t pouting - and her girlfriend’s grin grew wider. “Should’ve done that the first time.”

Adora snorted and turned towards the wall. Perhaps she should've. Yet… They might be joking about this, but it did feel weird to use She-Ra's power for something you could do without it. Even without magic. Like cheating.

Not that she would say that, or Catra would lecture her about not being stupid. Her girlfriend had strict views on fair fights and working more than you had to. Mainly, that both was stupid.

And they had been down here for a few hours already. Adora raised her hand and summoned - or conjured, according to Castaspella - her sword, then changed it into a drill. She looked at it, cocking her head. It seemed to be functional.

Taking a deep breath, she pushed the tip against the wall and started to drill. The tip went into and through the wall like a hot knife went through butter, as Glimmer liked to say. Rock dust and a few splinters flew, but she didn't mind it - her clothes would be cleaned next time she transformed. She-Ra's magic was convenient that way.

Also in other ways - she stumbled slightly when she suddenly felt a lack of resistance, but caught herself instantly. "I'm through!" she announced.

"I knew it!" Glimmer gloated.

"I knew it," Adora corrected her.

"Yes, yes. You were right. For once." Catra rolled her eyes again. "So, open up the tunnel."

That took a little longer. Halfway to clearing the entire wall, Catra suddenly held up her hand. "Stop! I heard something!"

"What?" Adora asked, freezing in the middle of carving through another stone.

"A… whooshing sound, or something." Catra's ears were twitching, and her tail was swishing back and forth.

“A ‘wooshing sound’?” Glimmer snorted. “Is that a word?”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “It sounded like that. Something is behind that wall.”

“Well, we better…” Adora started to say when Melog suddenly jumped up and sped past her, into the tunnel.

“Melog! Wait!” Catra yelled.

But the cat had already disappeared down the tunnel.

And Catra was about to climb after it.

*****

Samantha Carter kept her M4 trained on the alien looming over the Colonel, silently cursing herself. It must have arrived while she had been distracted by waiting for the Colonel to arrive. Waiting and worrying… She buried the thought, clenching her teeth. She could lambast herself for her unprofessional mistakes later. Now she had to focus on dealing with the situation at hand.

They were facing an alien. It had roughly the shape of a big cat, but in purple, no markings or stripes, and a mane and tail that looked transparent - almost like holograms. Glowing eyes that matched the mane.

And it was growling fiercely.

“Carter!” the Colonel hissed through clenched teeth. He was staring straight up at the creature, and his carbine was about a foot away from his hand - if he grabbed it, he might provoke the creature. “Mind doing something about this? Like, making it go away?”

“I’m not sure if it’s corporeal,” she told him. If she shot it and the bullets went through its body… the ricochets would endanger everyone. Especially the Colonel.

“Well, yeah, but I’m sure it’s dangerous,” he snapped back as he started to slowly try and slide away from it.

“It might be intelligent,” Daniel interjected. “Have you ever seen one like it, Teal'c?”

A stupid question, Sam knew - if Teal'c had recognised the alien, he would have told them so already.

“No,” Teal'c replied anyway. His staff was pointed at the animal, but as close as it was to the Colonel… the plasma blast would injure him whether or not it hit the body of the alien. Perhaps Daniel’s zat’nik’tel… that would be safe. Unless there was some interaction between the creature’s aura and the blast. And Daniel wasn’t the best shot.

The alien growled again. At Teal'c, she realised. Had it recognised him? Had it met Jaffa before? Could it tell Jaffa from humans? The differences were hard to tell without exposing their midriffs, but who knew what senses this creature had…

Her eyes widened when she heard footsteps. She shifted her carbine, aiming at the tunnel behind the alien, trusting Teal'c to keep the cat covered.

“Someone’s coming!” Daniel announced.

“Melog!” A figure appeared in the tunnel, then froze when they spotted SG-1. “Who’re you?”

Sam stared for a moment. The figure was humanoid but had cat-like features. Fur, twitching, cat-like ears, a tail. And she was female - the tight clothes she was wearing didn’t hide that. And she was unarmed. Or not, Sam corrected herself when the woman unsheathed claws on her fingers and feet. She didn’t attack, though - she must have realised they had her covered.

“We’re Tau’ri,” Daniel spoke up. “We’re travellers who ended up here by mistake. Who are you?”

“Travellers?” The woman’s ears twitched as the alien growled again. Her eyes widened. “Goa’uld?”

“No! We aren’t Goa’uld,” Daniel blurted out.

Sam hoped that they weren’t talking to a loyal servant of the local Goa’uld.

“What are Goa’uld?” the woman asked.

Daniel blinked. “They’re a species that…” he started to explain, but the alien cat cut him off with another growl.

“Parasitic snakes?” the cat-woman hissed, eyes darting to the cat for a moment.

She could understand the alien cat, Sam realised. Who was obviously intelligent. And didn’t like the Goa’uld.

“Yes, exactly,” Daniel went on, blissfully ignorant of this. “We’ve…”

More footsteps. “Catra! Melog!”

And Sam stared again as a huge blonde woman - easily seven foot tall - arrived, brandishing a giant sword. She drew to a stop next to the cat-woman - Catra? - and pointed her sword at them. “Who are you?”

“We’re Tau’ri, from Earth,” Daniel repeated. “We come in peace.”

“They’re servants of parasitic snakes,” the cat-woman cut in.

“Parasitic snakes?”

Two more figures arrived. They looked like humans. A man with a… bow and arrows? And a woman with a staff. Sword, bow and staff - if they didn’t end up dead, the Colonel would make a D&D joke, Sam was sure. As sure as she was that she wouldn’t reveal that she understood the joke.

“No! We aren’t servants of the Goa’uld!” Daniel exclaimed.

Another growl.

“He is!” the cat-woman said, pointing at Teal'c.

“I do not serve them. Not any more,” Teal'c replied. He didn’t show any emotion, but Sam could see that he was tense. Ready to take them all down.

“Yes. We’ve been kinda fighting them for some time,” the Colonel chimed in.

“He carries a snake in his body!”

“A larva - the Goa’uld use his people as hosts,” Daniel explained. “We cannot extract it without endangering his life. Please - we do not mean you any harm.”

“And yet you’re pointing your weapons at us,” the blonde woman replied.

“So are you,” the Colonel shot back. The cat growled at him, and he winced.

“You started it! And Melog doesn’t like you!” the cat-woman retorted.

“It’s a misunderstanding.” Daniel took a step towards the four. Sam gritted her teeth and shifted her position so he wouldn’t block her line of fire. The Colonel was still too close to the alien cat to get his carbine. “We oppose the Goa’uld - we have killed one of their leaders. In fact, we ended up here fleeing from one of their planets.”

“You fled to Etheria?” the blonde asked. “Like the Star Siblings?”

Star siblings? Sam didn’t remember any term like that.

“We travelled between the stars, yes,” Daniel said.

"Where's your ship? And how did you get past the frigates in orbit?" the other woman asked.

"And what are you doing here?" the man added.

Frigates in orbit? Sam's eyes widened. Despite the primitive weapons, these people must be a spacefaring civilisation. Or at least on a level to achieve orbit.

She glanced at the Colonel. He had realised it as well, she knew.

"We didn't arrive by ship," Daniel went on. "We arrived through the Stargate." He pointed at the ring behind them, which had gone inert.

And which, Sam realised with a gasp, didn't have a D.H.D. anywhere near it.

*****

Catra hissed. They were facing a group of armed strangers - armed strangers with parasitic snakes in them. Well, at least in one, possibly two of them, according to Melog. And Adora and the others were talking with them! Even though the tactical situation favoured them. They outnumbered the others. Melog had one of them - the oldest - locked down. Adora was close enough to get the big guy with the staff before he could do anything, and she would bet on Bow against the woman with the gun. Especially since the blonde seemed to be distracted by the ring thing behind them. The Stargate, according to them.

Well, that would explain the 'Gate' sign Adora had mentioned.

Anyway, Catra could take the guy with the glasses - he didn't seem to be much of a fighter - and Glimmer could teleport behind whoever made trouble. There was no need to talk like this.

"There's no D.H.D.!" the glasses guy exclaimed.

What was a D.H.D.?

“What? Carter!” the old man turned his head away from Melog.

“I… I don’t see any, Sir.”

“How could you miss that?”

“We were distracted by being under fire and waiting for you,” the glasses guy said.

“And it wasn’t relevant,” the big guy added - without taking his eyes off Adora, Catra noted. Points for identifying the biggest threat to them. But it wouldn’t help him anyway. No one could beat She-Ra.

“What is a D.H.D.?” Adora asked.

“It’s what is used to control the Stargate,” the glasses guy explained. “Without it, you can’t use it.”

“So, you’re stuck here unless we find one?” Adora cocked her head.

Trapped, Melog growled.

Catra blinked. Did Melog hide it with an illusion? It must have used illusions to sneak up on them, so hiding this other thing would not be too much of a stretch. “You know this gate, don't you?”

No. Only know of.

Well, that was something. Catra hated missing intel. Or giving information to the enemy. “So, did you see one?” she asked Melog.

No.

He wasn’t hiding one, then.

“So, we’re trapped here,” the old man said. “And apparently, their cat is their gate expert.”

Cat? Catra narrowed her eyes. Ah. He was talking about Melog.

"You know the Stargate?" Glasses guy was looking at Melog. "Uh… can they understand us? Or do you need to translate?"

Catra snorted. "Melog can understand you just fine."

"Ah." The man nodded. "So…"

"We still don't know who you are and why we should trust you," Catra told him.

"We come in peace. And by accident," the man replied. "We do not mean you any harm."

"You could be lying," Catra shot back. "You're carrying snake parasites that Melog really doesn't like." And she trusted Melog. Almost as much as she trusted Adora.

"I am not controlled by the Goa'uld," the huge guy said. "And I will die before I let the larva mature and take over anyone."

Well, anyone could say that. But the guy did sound like he meant it. Not like Adora 'I can't lie to save myself' honest, but… determined.

He still could be lying.

"Look… let's lower the weapons," the glasses guy said, holstering his own tiny thing. "Let's deescalate. None of us wants to fight. I hope so, at least," he added, looking at Melog.

Melog growled again. *Don't trust snakes.*

"Can the snakes hurt us?" Catra asked. "Like… control us?"

Burrow into you.

She shuddered. "The snakes bury into you," she told the others.

"Ew!" Glimmer grimaced.

“That’s why they’re parasites!” Bow exclaimed. “And you have one inside you!”

“Not like that,” the glasses guy said. “The Goa’uld use Jaffa to, ah, grow their young, but they do not control them as they control the Tau’ri. But please, let’s lower our weapons. Guys?” He was talking to his friends. “We’re stranded here. We need help. And it’s clear that they won’t trust us easily.”

The woman looked at the old guy. That must be their leader. “Sir?”

“Well, I don’t have a gun to lower… but we’re in close quarters, and I’m pretty sure this cat can shred me before anyone can shoot it.” He sighed. “Let’s talk.”

The glasses guy smiled as the woman lowered her gun and the big guy put the staff up. “So… I’m Daniel Jackson. These are Colonel Jack O’Neill, Captain Samantha Carter and Teal'c.”

Catra narrowed her eyes. It was a gesture of trust… or it could be a trap. But either way, they had an even greater advantage. If these people tried anything…

Then Adora lowered her sword - and put it on her back. “Alright.”

And Bow lowered his bow. Catra clenched her teeth. So much for having an advantage!

Glimmer took a step forward. “I am Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon. This is She-Ra, Princess of Power. Bow and Catra. And Melog.”

“Glimmer? Bow? Princess of Power?” The old guy - O’Neill - blinked.

“Sir!” the woman - Carter - hissed.

Even Jackson sent a glance at the old man before smiling again. “Thank you. We are honoured to meet you and apologise for

entering your realm without permission. Ah… how do we address you?"

*****

"Your Glowing Highness?" Jack O'Neill clenched his teeth a little too late to keep his comment from slipping out.

"Jack!" Daniel looked aghast.

"Colonel!" Carter too.

But he couldn't help it - he had been lying far too close to an alien cat creature for far too long. And those names… Even if they were a translation quirk, how could anyone resist?

And the cat-woman - named Catra? What the hell? - giggled. "'Your Glowing Highness'! That's almost as good as Sparkles!"

"Catra!" the big blonde hissed.

And the alien cat chuffed or something. It had changed colours too, for a moment, Jack noticed. Perhaps if it was distracted, he could reach his carbine… No. They were talking now. And this group seemed to loathe the Goa'uld, which made them OK in Jack's book. And they were all so young… barely twenty, by his guess. Unless that was old for a cat-woman.

"Just call me Glimmer," the supposed queen said. "We aren't at Court." She was frowning at Jack, though.

He smiled back - he had seen worse glares. Like the one Carter was sending at him. "Glimmer it is. Call me Jack."

She nodded. "You're the leader of your group."

Had it been obvious? Daniel had told them their ranks, but would they have understood that? Jack told himself not to underestimate the kids. "I'm the leader of SG-1, yes. Do you mind if I get up? Talking to you while I'm on my back feels a little weird." He

managed not to add the very off-colour joke about being on his back that came to mind. See, Carter, I can control myself!

"As long as you don't try to attack us," the blonde amazon said. Adora She-Ra, or something. Daniel was probably analysing the meanings of their names.

"Thank you." Jack kept the sarcasm down as he slowly backed off a little more from the cat - no quick movements - and got up. After a moment's hesitation, he picked up his carbine and slung it over his shoulder. He always felt better conducting negotiations when he was armed.

The kids seemed to relax, he noticed.

"So, Glimmer, once again, our apologies for entering your realm," Daniel repeated himself as he gave them his usual charming smile. One of those days, he'd send the wrong signals to people, Jack knew.

"It's not exactly my realm," Glimmer replied. "This is the Whispering Woods. Bright Moon and Plumeria share the responsibility for the area. Bright Moon is my kingdom."

"Ah." Daniel nodded.

So, they were in disputed territory. And there were more kingdoms. Jack grinned - good to know. And good to know that this kid wasn't the ruler of the planet.

"So, you arrived here by the Stargate," the boy - Bow - said. "And you are stuck here since you can't activate it from this side."

Right. Daniel needed the 'don't blurt out information' talk again, Jack reminded himself.

"Yes," Carter said. "We need a D.H.D. A…"

Jack grinned. "A Dial Home Device, as we call it. It's round, looks a little like a weird sundial, and has the symbols you see on the

Stargate. Found it lying around by chance?”

“No.” “Nope.” “Don’t think so.” “Didn’t pay attention.”

“It might be around,” the blonde said. “We’re still exploring these ruins.”

“Looks like we’re stuck until we find it,” Jack said. Carter might be able to create a replacement device, but it had taken Stargate Command fifteen years to build the supercomputer to run the Stargate, and it still didn’t work perfectly. Stranded on an alien planet, she’d need… He pushed the thought away. Focus on the task at hand, he reminded himself.

“Uh… you said you fled from enemies. Will they follow you through the gate?” Adora asked.

“That’s…” Daniel trailed off. “The D.H.D. was hit when I was dialling. It’s possible that it got stuck, but…”

“They would have reopened the gate and followed us if they could,” Carter said.

“Yes,” Jack agreed. “Jaffa don’t give up easily.” Not when their lives, and the lives of their families, might depend on it.

“If their orders were to capture us,” Teal'c added. “If their orders were to drive us off, they might not have followed us even if they could.

“The gate went out as soon as you came through, Sir,” Carter said. “And the D.H.D. was damaged. I doubt that it’s functional, but we cannot dismiss the danger, either.”

“Great.” The cat-woman sighed. “We’ve got a portal straight to another alien invasion force.”

“Well… It’s a small portal?” the blonde smiled weakly. “Can we brick it up?”

“The opening of the wormhole destroys almost anything in the way,” Carter told her. “You would need a special material or bury the entire gate to block it.”

“Or you just seal the chamber,” Jack suggested.

“That would still allow anyone to arrive. And they would be stuck here,” Glimmer said. “We’ll ask Entrapta if she can block the gate.”

“Entrapta?” Jack tilted his head. What was it with those names?

“Princess of Dryl,” Glimmer told him. “She and Bow are experts on First Ones technology.”

“She’s better,” the boy said with a smile.

“But you’re not a slouch either!” Adora added.

“So, where’s Entrapta?” Jack asked. They had to stay focused.

“Trying to fix the main console,” Adora told him.

“I’ll fetch her,” Bow said. “She’ll love this.”

Jack suddenly had a bad feeling about this.

*****

Adora kept an eye on the new arrivals while Bow went to fetch Entrapta. They didn’t look like they’d attack her or her friends, but better safe than sorry - they still hadn’t verified their story, after all. Not that she knew how to verify if they were stranded here. But she knew they were dangerous. Well, most of them - the guy with the glasses didn’t seem dangerous. Or he was a better actor than Double Trouble.

“Sir, if we don’t find the D.H.D….” the woman, Carter, told the older man in a low voice.

“We’ll cross that bridge if we get to it, Carter,” he replied. “For now, let’s be optimistic.”

"Optimistic? You, Jack?"

"Hey! I'm always optimistic, Daniel."

"You always assume the worst."

"Not always. And I'm just being realistic."

"So, you mean you're not always realistic since you claim you don't always assume the worst?"

"Daniel! Not in front of our new friends!"

Catra snickered. "Oh, do continue."

"See?"

"Honesty is a good policy, Jack."

So, Carter called the man 'sir', while Daniel called him Jack. Which must mean he wasn't a soldier. Adora nodded at her conclusion. But that left the tall black guy who hadn't said much so far. Was he a soldier?

But their visitors had fallen silent now.

"So, you're from Earth, you said?" Catra spoke up. She sounded casual, just making conversation while they waited, but Adora knew her too well to fall for it. Catra was being sneaky.

"Yes, we're from Earth," Daniel replied.

"And you travel through Stargates to fight evil parasitic snakes." Catra didn't try to hide the hint of scepticism in her tone.

"The Goa'uld, yes," the man confirmed. "Although most of our missions are simple exploration missions."

"We just keep stumbling into Goa'uld, and suddenly the mission gets all complicated," O'Neill added. "Or simpler, since it becomes

all about shooting the enemy before he shoots you." He grinned at them. "Or blowing them up."

Catra snorted in response. "Ah, that kind of simple."

Adora rolled her eyes. "And you accidentally ended up here, unable to go back."

"And we could have an invasion arrive at any moment." Glimmer shook her head. "Another one."

"Oh, yes, Your Glowiness," Catra told her. "But never fear, She-Ra's here."

Adora cleared her throat and pointedly looked at their visitors when Catra and Glimmer turned towards her. Glimmer blushed a little, but Catra scoffed.

"Ah… Forgive me if this is prying," Daniel said, "but you don't seem overly concerned with an invasion."

"She-Ra here can handle it," Catra replied before Adora or Glimmer could say anything. "And as you explained, we can replace her with a few tons of rock." She smirked at Adora.

Adora snorted - she knew what Catra was hinting at.

"Ah… you shouldn't underestimate the Goa'uld," Daniel said. "They are very old and experienced and often use quite brutal or underhanded means to pursue their goals."

Catra chuckled. "We've got experience with that."

"Mainly thanks to you," Glimmer retorted. "And we don't know anything about those Goa'uld."

Catra glared at her in return.

Adora sighed. She knew Catra was trying to impress their visitors to keep them honest, but… "I can handle it," she told them. "But

we do need to find a more permanent solution."

"Can the gate be moved?" Catra asked.

"Yes. Although it's not easy," Carter replied.

"She-Ra can carry it." Catra waved her hand. "Problem solved."

Adora snorted. She probably could - she could throw a tank, after all - but she wasn't some beast of burden.

"Except for the fact that we're still stuck here," O'Neill said. "Our… friends at home must be worrying."

"You mean your army," Catra told him. "Or they wrote you off. Your missions seem to be rather dangerous."

"We don't write our people off!" the older man protested. He seemed genuinely angry at the assumption, Adora realised.

"Neither do we," Glimmer took a step forward. "But some of our enemies considered everyone but themselves disposable."

Catra pressed her lips together and didn't say anything. Adora wanted to sigh again. Catra had changed. Her girlfriend just needed to accept that. For good. She smiled at her, but Catra didn't seem to notice.

"Will they send a team after you?" Glimmer asked.

The others looked at each other. "I don't think they know where we are," Daniel explained. "We arrived here by accident, travelling from another planet. Our… friends… wouldn't have any way to find out where we are."

"Well, theoretically, if the Stargate on Trias has remained stuck with this gate address, then a team could find us should they be able to secure the Stargate there," Carter explained. "However, the odds of that happening…" She winced.

“So, you’re stuck here until you find a way home,” Adora summed up.

“As they already said,” Catra commented.

“We just need a D.H.D.,” Daniel said. “If you just discovered this facility, then it could be in storage somewhere, and you just haven’t found it yet.”

Adora nodded. That sounded plausible.

Catra was about to say something, but she cocked her head instead, ears twitching in that cute manner that made Adora want to caress them. “Bow and Entrapta are coming,” her girlfriend said.

“A Stargate! A Portal! New Technology! Oh, I can’t wait to examine it!” Entrapta’s voice could be heard.

A few seconds later, she appeared in the door, walking on her hair tendrils while holding her recorder. “Hello, everyone! This is so exciting! Oh, there it is!”

Their visitors stared.

*****

A teenager? was Samantha Carter’s first thought. Then she saw the woman’s face. No, twenty to thirty - just short. Shorter than Queen Glimmer. And she was… walking with her hair. No, that couldn’t be hair. It was moving, carrying the woman. And yet it looked like hair. Some sort of nanostrands? Microstructures that allowed it to move like muscles?

“Hi!”

“Hello,” the Colonel nodded.

“Hello.” Daniel looked speechless for a change.

“I’m Entrapta! You’re the travellers from another planet? And you arrived through a portal! Fascinating? Do you mind if I scan you? Just to check if you have some weird radiation or anything else we could use to determine your home planet.”

Belatedly, Sam greeted the woman as well. “Hello.”

“Hi! You’re the scientist of your group?” Entrapta beamed at her, which looked a little creepy as she was still hanging down from her hair.

So, they had noticed that Sam was a scientist. That meant they knew what a scientist was - well, they already knew that, what with the remarks about frigates in orbit. Still, why would they use bows and swords? A cultural relic from a Goa’uld occupation?

Metallic steps drew her attention back to the tunnel, and she froze. A huge, round robot entered the chamber. It was the size of a small car and walking on articulated legs.

“What the…?”

“That’s Emily!” the woman announced. “She’s my assistant - and bodyguard, I guess.”

The robot beeped, and the woman nodded. “Exactly!”

She turned and pointed a device at them. “So, let’s scan you!”

“Whoa! Wait a minute!” the Colonel protested. “What exactly are you planning to do?”

“Gathering data about you, of course! You’re an alien species - at least one of you is an alien for sure, but the others could be as well.”

“It’s considered rude to scan people without their consent,” Daniel said.

“Why?” The woman cocked her head - somehow without unbalancing her hair. “It’s just gathering data.”

“It, ah, is a potential violation of our privacy,” Daniel replied. “Medical data is considered confidential in our home culture.”

“Really? Well, I need to scan you. What if you carry some alien viruses or bacteria? Or are suffering from an allergy to anything here?” The woman held up the device and started pushing buttons.

And the tall blonde - Adora - who had raised her hand, lowered it again.

“She’s right,” the cat-woman muttered.

“Yes, but…”

“No, you’re right,” Sam said. “This is a medical necessity.”

“Carter!” the Colonel protested.

“She is correct, Sir.” It was only sensible to check them for diseases.

“Yes, but you could’ve said it a little more diplomatically.” He was almost pouting. Not that Sam would ever tell him that.

“O-K! Now let’s analyse this!” The woman - Entrapta announced. Pushing a few more buttons. “And while we wait, let’s do science!” Her mask, which had rested on top of her head, slid down and covered her face as she approached the Stargate. “Oh, First Ones style!”

“First Ones?” Daniel asked at once.

“What we call the people who built this temple,” the young man told them. The group was predominantly made up of women, Sam suddenly realised. There was only one man, and he was clearly not a leader. She’d have to point this out to Daniel.

“Oh! This is a fascinating material!”

“It’s Naquadah,” Sam told her. “A rare, super-dense mineral.”

“Oh, yes. Yes. Really fascinating. I need to take a sample to analyse it.”

“Please don’t damage our only way home,” the Colonel said.

“Oh, right. Though a little sample won’t hurt - it’s already scratched.” One hair tendril separated and grabbed a tool.

“How are you doing this?” Sam blurted out, both to make the woman reconsider damaging the Stargate and to satisfy her curiosity.

“Doing what?”

“Your… hair. How do you move the strands?”

“Oh.” The woman turned around to face and smile at Sam. “It’s my magic talent. It’s more useful than you might think!”

“Magic talent?” Daniel asked.

“Yes. Inborn magic. Some princesses can control plants, some can control the sea, I can control my hair. And it’s very useful for doing fine work.”

Magic. Sam was tempted to lower her estimate of this planet’s technical level. On the other hand, there was a lot of technology that, if not quite understood, would appear to be magic. And some species had talents that matched some definitions of magic. She’d have to ask Daniel to look into this. The last thing they needed was some cultural misunderstanding. Or some blind spots due to preconceptions. Something, fortunately, Daniel lacked.

“Magic hair. Now I’ve seen everything,” the Colonel commented. “Can you pull a rabbit out of your hat as well?”

Unfortunately, the Colonel easily made up for that. Sam winced.

The woman, Entrapta, didn't seem to mind, though. "No, I can't. I don't have a hat or a rabbit."

But the rest of the group was glaring at the Colonel. Even the robot seemed, somehow, to show some annoyance.

"Sorry, Daniel said, smiling again. "We don't have magic on our planet, so we're not quite used to it."

"Oh, we know," the blonde woman said, smiling. "We've been working hard to return magic to all the worlds without it, but it's going slowly. But we'll get around to your home planet, don't worry!"

Sam blinked.

What?

*****

The Gate

Whispering Woods, Etheria, July 10th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"What?" The blonde woman was gaping as if Adora had been stuttering.

Catra frowned. "We're bringing magic back," she told her. "It's just going to take a while." No need to let them get high expectations.

"Magic?" The guy with glasses stared at them. "What exactly do you mean by magic?"

Catra sighed. Were those guys slow or what? "Magic. You know, the power that lets you teleport, control plants - or hair - and turn spaceships into plants?"

"What?" the blonde repeated herself.

"Magic." Entrapta beamed at them - Catra could tell even with her mask up. "It's a way of manipulating a form of energy that is commonly called 'magic' as well, which is, kinda confusing, I guess. But that's fine - you haven't had access to magic in this sector for a thousand years or more, so you can't be expected to understand everything at once.

"A form of energy?" The blonde would make a good recorder, Catra thought with a smirk, the way she kept repeating stuff.

"Yes." Entrapta nodded as if that explained everything.

The old guy who had been making fun of Entrapta shook his head. "There is no such a thing as magic."

"Really?" Glimmer narrowed her eyes at him.

Catra grinned. That should be good. Entrapta was their friend. And they wouldn't let someone mock her for her… quirks.

“Yes, really,” the old guy told her.

“Colonel!” the blonde hissed.

“Jack! This is obviously a cultural difference.”

“No, it’s just ignorance,” Glimmer spat - and teleported next to them.

All of them were shocked. Or at least surprised - even the tall, dark guy twitched.

“What do you call this?” Glimmer challenged them.

“We’ve seen transporters before,” the old guy replied - he was still looking wary, though.

“But nothing like this, Jack!” Glasses gushed. “This is like… teleportation! Instant transportation! And we didn’t see any rings!”

“Yes, this is Glimmer’s innate magical talent. She can teleport using magic,” Entrapta said, nodding at the others. “Just like I can control my hair.”

“Perhaps they have trace elements of Naquadah or something similar in their blood, and it allows them to wield devices like the Hara’Kesh,” the blonde mumbled.

“But Sam!” Glasses objected. “Why would they try to convince us that there is magic if it’s actually technology?”

“Oh, actually, magic is part of technology, at least according to some definitions.” Entrapta smiled. “If you have the talent, you can learn to cast spells, and they follow the laws of magic. It’s science!”

This was getting out of hand, Catra realised. They were discussing magic and technology with a bunch of intruders as if they were on Mystacore and not in the middle of an ancient installation of the First Ones they had barely begun to explore. “How about we

discuss that stuff once we've hashed out the more important bits? Like whether or not there's one of those 'D.H.D.s' around?" And once they had confirmed that this installation didn't have some homicidal bots waiting in secret rooms to go after all intruders. Catra didn't want a repat of that particular excursion.

Melog growled in agreement.

"Good idea." Adora smiled at her, and Catra smiled back with a warm feeling in her chest before she caught herself. They could flirt when they weren't standing in melee range of a group of still suspicious strangers.

"So, first: Are they safe, or are they controlled by alien parasitic snakes?" Catra asked. Melog certainly wasn't warming up to them.

"Well, my scan should… ah! It finished while we talked. Yes!" Entrapta slipped her mask up on her head and peered at her recorder. "Ah. None of you carries dangerous or unknown diseases as far as my scanner can tell - and it can tell a lot. And none of you has a parasitic or other organism connected to your central nervous system. So, you probably aren't controlled by those 'Goa'uld'."

"Probably?" Adora asked.

Catra looked at Melog. Her friend was still tense.

"Well, they could be controlled by other means, right?" Entrapta cocked her head sideways. "We shouldn't assume that there's only one way to achieve the same result; that's what leads to failed research!"

"Blackmail, hostages, bribes," Catra explained with a shrug. "Whatever works."

"I would rather die than obey the False Gods!" the huge guy growled. "And so would my family."

Catra narrowed her eyes. That sounded… well, she'd keep an eye on the guy. Anyone who'd sacrifice their family like that was dangerous. And probably not quite stable - she knew all about being fanatically devoted to one thing. And how dangerous that made you to everyone - including your friends. Knew it far too well.

"We are fighting the snakes. We don't obey them," the old guy said.

"But you had one inside you," Entrapta went on, pointing at the blonde with one hair tendril. "I can see where it accessed your spine - it's not quite healed yet. Fascinating! And your blood! It's full of this new metal. Relatively, of course - you're not in any danger of succumbing to heavy metal poisoning. I think - I'm not a Healer."

The blonde obviously didn't think that this was fascinating, nor was she particularly relieved that she wouldn't be dying to poison. "Yes," she spat through clenched teeth.

"It was a very recent and very traumatic experience," Glasses said.

"Oh? How so?" Entrapta blinked.

But before she could ask for more details, Adora took a step forward. "Yes, we understand. We know about traumatic experiences."

Catra, meanwhile, glanced at Entrapta and grimaced.

Her friend blinked, and then her eyes widened. "Oh! That kinda experience. Right! No asking for details!" She nodded firmly. "Anyway, they aren't currently controlled by parasites."

That didn't mean that they were trustworthy, of course. Catra knew that better than most as well. "What about the snake inside him?" she asked.

“As I said, the snake embryo in Teal’c’s stomach is only connected to his bloodstream so it can receive nourishment and oxygen, but has no connection to his brain or spine.”

Adora blinked. “Wait. It’s not just… you’re really pregnant with a snake?”

*****

“We’re calling him Junior,” Jack O’Neill said. Teal’c raised an eyebrow at him, but that was to be expected. A little humour should diffuse the situation.

“It’s not exactly a pregnancy,” Daniel tried to explain. “It’s more like… like an incubator.”

“That’s not much of a difference,” the Queen - who could barely be twenty - said.

“It’s not my child.” Teal’c was getting annoyed. Jack could tell. Fortunately, the others didn’t know Teal’c like Jack did. “And if I could, I would get rid of it.”

The other group exchanged some glances. Except for the princess with the magical hair - she was studying her scanner again. “It’s kind of a symbiont, actually - it provides him with an immune system. Otherwise, he would die.”

“The Jaffa were genetically engineered to lack an immune system without an implanted Goa’uld embryo,” Carter explained. “It’s a way to control them.”

That got a reaction - even the slightly off science princess looked shocked.

“They did what?” The amazon gasped. “That’s… that’s horrible!”

“They’re forced to serve or die…” Queenie suddenly looked a few years older. And angrier.

And the big cat growled.

The boy, though, frowned. “But… if you have an embryo per, ah, Jaffa, wouldn’t that mean that you have more Goa’uld than Jaffa?”

“Sounds more than a little top-heavy as a command structure,” the catwoman added.

“The Goa’uld don’t really care much for their offspring,” Daniel told them.

“They eat them,” Teal’c said.

Once more, the kids looked shocked. “They eat their own?” Blondie blurted out.

“Cannibalistic tendencies have been observed in many animal species, especially if they spawn a lot of offspring, but to see it in a sapient species is rare,” their scientist commented. She didn’t look shocked, Jack noticed.

“No wonder Melog hates them,” the catwoman mumbled.

“They’re evil,” Teal’c said.

“But… even the babies?” The amazon - Adora, Jack reminded himself - looked at Teal’c’s stomach.

“They have genetic memory - each of them knows what their progenitor knows,” Daniel explained.

“That’s handy for getting intel.”

“Catra!”

“What? I’m just saying - if all you need is one of the snakes to find out what they know, then that’s a huge weakness.”

“They’re still children!” Adora shook her head.

“Still better than being eaten,” Catra retorted.

The blonde stared at her, then closed her mouth. “That’s…”

“In order to interrogate a Goa’uld larva, you’d have to present it with a host,” Carter interrupted their spat. She pressed her lips together, no doubt remembering her own possession.

“And that would be morally unacceptable since the host would be effectively dead,” Daniel went on.

To their credit, most of the others nodded at that. Though the catwoman - named Catra, really! - struck Jack as a little too pragmatic to be fully convinced. She reminded him of a few spooks he had known in his youth.

“So, you’re saying they’re born evil?” Adora asked.

“Everyone can change,” Entrapta protested. “No matter the circumstances of your birth!”

Adora nodded, as did the others, though Catra looked away. Interesting.

But they really should focus on searching the area now. The kids seemed friendly, but that might change if more locals were brought in. If they found a D.H.D., then Jack’s team could be back at SGC before anyone back home started worrying, and then they could prepare a proper diplomatic mission to this planet. He cleared his throat. “So, how about we look for our missing device? We wouldn’t want to impose on you, after all.” He gave them his best smile.

“That sounds good.” Catra nodded.

“But we still need to guard the gate,” Adora pointed out.

“You can do that,” Catra told her. “We’ll look for their device. But let’s stick together for safety.”

“Never split the party,” Jack agreed. As expected, Daniel the nerd frowned at him, but Carter didn’t react to his joke. Neither did

Teal’c, but again, that was par for the course.

“So… Adora stays here,” Queenie said.

“But I’m the one who can read First Ones writing.”

“You’re also the best way to seal the gate here. If we find anything we need translated, we can call you.”

“But…”

“She’s right,” Catra agreed. “Someone has to watch the gate.”

“You’ve got the best eyes, as you claimed before!”

“And that’s why I’m going to look for their device. You can watch the gate - you don’t need my eyes to spot an invasion force trying to come through.” The catwoman smiled and briefly hugged the amazon. “We’ll be back soon.”

“Daniel, stay here as well,” Jack said.

“But, Jack!”

“You two can talk about translating.” And he could keep an eye on the blonde amazon while staying out of the way of any traps or ambushes. And if the group turned on them, Daniel wouldn’t be caught in the crossfire.

“Oh, right!”

Besides, if things went as they usually did, Daniel would be charming the socks off the woman. “Just don’t get married by accident.”

“Jack!” Daniel looked annoyed. And Carter frowned at him. Right. No joking about wives.

“Sorry,” Jack mumbled. “Now, let’s get this show on the road! We’ve got a D.H.D. to find!”

“If it’s made from the same material as the gate, then I can scan for it!”

“You can, Entrpata?” Adora asked.

“It’s simple data gathering.”

“Do it,” Queen Glimmer ordered.

Well, that should speed things up.

*****

And there went the others. Adora sighed as she watched the group leave, Emily bringing up the rear. She still didn’t like staying behind and guarding the portal. Of course, as She-Ra, she could repel an invasion through such an obvious choke point - even a young cadet would be able to plan such a battle, except for Kyle - but she was also the best choice to deal with lingering guard bots, traps or monsters that had ventured into the ruins. And she really didn’t like letting her friends face such dangers without her.

“So… you can read Ancient script?” The man who had stayed with her asked. Daniel.

“Ancient?” She cocked her head to the side.

“This one.” He pointed at a text on the wall. “It’s the language of the Ancients. That’s our name for the civilization which built the Stargates.”

“Oh.” So, the First Ones had built the gates? That figured. “We call them the First Ones,” she told him.

“Ah.” He nodded. “I’ve been studying their language for years.”

“Ah, yes. It takes a long time of studying and such to learn it, right?” Adora smiled at him. There was no way she was telling him that she was born with the ability to read First Ones script.

Not after all the talk about genetic memory. “I kind of studied history,” she went on.

“Oh? You did?” His face lit up. “That’s great! What do you know about the impact the Ancients - the First Ones - had on your world?”

They had tried to blow it up to defeat Horde Prime. And, if not for Mara and Adora, would have succeeded. But she couldn’t tell him that, either. “Well, they left those ruins,” she said instead. “And their technology. Though few can understand it. Other than that…” She shrugged. “Not many can understand their language.” Not even dedicated historians like Bow’s dads.

“A topic for academicians, then?”

“Historians, mostly,” she replied. Perhaps she should’ve played dumb.

“Like yourself.”

“Oh…” She grimaced. “I had to cut my studies short because of the war.” It was true. Kinda. A little. She had missed Force Captain orientation.

“The war?” He looked surprised.

“Against the Horde. Invaders,” she told him. “They tried to conquer Etheria for decades. We finally defeated them a year ago.”

His eyes widened. “That’s… very recent.”

“Etheria was hidden from them for a thousand years,” she explained.

“And then they found you?”

“Something like that, yes. It was a bit more complicated.” And not something she liked to talk about. “Anyway, you studied the

Ancients?”

“As much as I’ve managed,” he told her with a sigh. “There aren’t many artefacts left from their time. It’s a miracle that there’s anything left.” He looked at the gate. “I still am awed that this is over five million years old and is working as well as it was on the first day. Or so we assume.”

“Five million years old?” She stared at him. “But…” Adora wasn’t a historian, but she knew that the First Ones had arrived a thousand years ago. Not five million years ago. “Are you sure?”

“Over five million years ago, actually. That’s when the last Stargates were built,” he told her. “All our research confirmed it so far.”

“Then we need to have Entrapta date this gate. If this is five million years old…” Adora didn’t know what it meant, but it was important.

“How old did you think it was?”

Oh. She pressed her lips together for a moment. Should she lie? They might see through it. “The ruins are about a thousand years old,” she said. “That’s when the First Ones arrived.”

“Ancients, a thousand years ago? But… they all vanished from the galaxy five million years ago. Approximately.”

That was weird. “Are you sure?” The galaxy was big, after all.

“We were. If we have to rewrite history…” He beamed at her. “This could be a historic discovery! Perhaps a colony of the Ancients survived?” Then he frowned. “Or another species could have been using their language and script. Or just their script. Like the Goa’uld.”

“Ah.” Adora didn’t know what to say. She wasn’t a historian. She was just a First One… Oh. “How did the Ancients look?”

“Ah… as far as we know, like us.”

“Oh.”

“Yes. they could probably pass for humans.”

“Or Tau’ri, right?”

“We call ourselves humans, but others call us Tau’ri.”

Adora blinked. “I see. And you’re aliens.”

“Well… the Goa’uld took humans in the past, kidnapped them from our planet and spread them across the galaxy through the gate network. That’s why so many planets are populated by humans.”

“And you think we’re humans as well.” Well, Glimmer, Bow and the others. Adora was a First One. And Catra was… Catra.”

He looked a little embarrassed. “Well, yes… the odds of a species independently evolving to look like us… I assume a gene test should tell us if we’re the same species.”

She nodded. “Entrapta will probably do that anyway.”

“Ah. She seems very enthusiastic.”

So enthusiastic, she had eagerly worked for the Horde. But that was not her fault. Not entirely, at least. Entrapta had been manipulated by Catra as well. Adora nodded. “Yes.”

“Like Sam, I guess.” He smiled.

*****

The tunnel ahead looked empty, but Samantha Carter knew that looks couldn’t be trusted. Not in a facility such as this one. Exploring Ancient ruins was a dangerous task.

“I don’t like this,” Catra mumbled. “This is too easy. We should’ve encountered a monster or a bot at least by now.”

“Don’t be so pessimistic,” the man told her. “We’re bound to have some luck with ancient ruins, one of these days.”

“That’s both correct and incorrect,” Entrapta said. “While it’s improbable that every place we visit has traps and guardian creatures or bots, that doesn’t mean any particular installation, such as this one, is any more likely to be unguarded than the one before. The odds of a particular outcome are roughly the same each time you encounter it, after all. That’s simple maths.”

“Well,” Catra said, “this tunnel before us is likely to be a trap. It just smells like it.”

“Do we have a thief with us?”

And there was the Dungeons and Dragons joke. Sam suppressed a sigh. “Sir?” she asked.

“Just a joke,” the Colonel replied. “About a game I used to play,” he added, nodding to the others with them, “when I was much younger. Thieves could detect traps.”

“A game?” The man - Bow, and carrying a bow and arrows; Daniel would have a field day trying to puzzle but the cultural significance of the name - asked. “What kind of game?”

He didn’t expect them to discuss games in the middle of an Ancient installation, did he?

“It’s like a board game. You play adventurers and explorers in a sort of maze,” the Colonel replied.

Sam wasn’t even sure if this culture had board games.

“Oh! Do you use miniatures?” Apparently, they not only had board games, but Bow was a fan of them.

“Yes?” The Colonel obviously hadn’t expected that response.

“Great!”

“Bow! We’re not about to ‘wargame’ this.” And Queen Glimmer wasn’t a fan.

“You do wargames?” The Colonel cocked his head.

“Yes!”

“Once. We did that once,” the queen corrected Bow. “And it was awful.”

Sam cleared her throat. “Can your scanner detect anything in the tunnel?” She asked Entrapta.

“Hm? Oh, yes. No Naquadah in the tunnel,” the woman replied without looking up from her device. “That’s a fascinating metal. I can’t wait to experiment with it.”

Oh. Sam refrained from cursing. “You have to be very cautious with it. It can enhance the power of explosions to a level your research facility might not be able to handle.”

“Really?” Entrapta was beaming at her. “I *have* to test that!”

“Err…” Bow looked a little pale. “But under strict safety protocols, right?”

“And not near Bright Moon,” Queen Glimmer added.

“And do it by remote.” Catra was still looking down the tunnel. Her eyes were like a cat’s, but Sam didn’t know if the woman could actually see in the dark as well as that indicated. Or whether or not her heterochromia affected her senses in any way.

“Oh. Something is moving ahead of us!” Entrapta piped up. “I knew my motion detector would end up working!”

“Can you detect what kind of creature is moving?” Catra asked, just as the cat, Melog, started to growl. “Watch out! Monster incoming!”

Sam aimed her M4 down the tunnel and moved to the wall, crouching down. The Colonel did the same on the other side with his M4A1. “What’s coming?”

“It’s moving like a snake,” Entrapta announced.

“Snakes? Why did it have to be snakes?” the Colonel commented.

“Well, they’re native to the area…” Entrapta started to explain

“Not now!” Glimmer snapped. “It’s coming!”

And there it was. It was a snake - or a worm - and it was huge. The head was the size of a human torso, but it had multiple, brightly glowing eyes. And fangs the size of Sam’s lower arm. For a moment, she hesitated. Could they shoot the snake? Or would that be…

Next to her, Bow released his arrow. It struck the snake in the open mouth, and it reeled, knocking its head against the ceiling, hard enough to shake loose dirt from it.

The Colonel fired, Sam joining him a moment later. Short bursts into the thing’s wide-open mouth, where no scales could protect it.

The snake roared and charged them, mouth wide open. Sam fought the urge to turn and flee and kept firing. Twenty yards. Fifteen. This would get ugly.

Another arrow hit the ground in front of the snake, releasing a green mass - and the snake got stuck. And a laser bolt struck the side of the thing, leaving a long scorch mark.

“Aim for the mouth!” the Colonel snapped.

Teal’c shot as well, sending a blast down the creature’s maw. Sam kept firing until she had emptied her whole magazine - two left, she automatically reminded herself - into the creature.

Which finally collapsed, green blood oozing out of its mouth.

Sam sighed with relief.

And Catra cursed them, holding her ears. “Warn me next time!”

“Oh! You’re using a chemical propellant to fire metal bullets at the target! Fascinating! What advantages does it offer over energy-based weapons? I assume you don’t have to deal with losing focus at longer ranges, but the drop-off in kinetic energy would probably be a problem, right?”

“Wow. Carter, she sounds like you when you discover a new thing.”

Sam glared at the Colonel. She wasn’t like that. Not at all.

*****

Those weapons were more effective than Catra had expected. At least at this range. Much higher rate of fire than a bow, and they did take down the monster. If only they weren’t so damn loud - her ears were still ringing.

She knelt down next to the monster - a Creeping Worm, at least according to the simulations she had done as a cadet - and looked at the wounds in its maw. Small holes, from what she could see. And the bullets hadn’t gone through the skull of the worm. But it had been enough to kill it. And people weren’t as tough as such a worm. “How good are they at going through armour?” she asked.

“Depends on the armour,” the old guy said.

“We can’t really say, not without a sample of the armour in question,” the blonde woman added.

One non-answer and an attempt to gather more information about them. These people weren't bad at the game. But Catra hadn't really been asking them.

"I would assume, based upon the penetration of the worm's skull, and the lack of exit wounds, that they would go through standard Horde field uniforms," Entrapta said. "A Bright Moon Guard's breastplate might stop it, as long as it's not too close."

That wasn't too bad at all. Quite nasty, actually - for the size of these weapons. Bow whistled, obviously impressed as well. Glimmer didn't look like she was happy about hearing that her soldiers would be vulnerable to those weapons. Well, she shouldn't be.

"Slightly better than a Horde light laser rifle, then," Catra summed up. They had seen Prime's bots use those against them often enough to compare. Far too often.

Entrapta blinked, then nodded. "Somewhat. It depends on the circumstances. I could make armour that would repel those bullets, of course. And it's definitely weaker than Emily's main blaster, I think."

Much lighter than either, however. And the rate of fire… "But it needs ammunition, I guess," Catra asked. And a lot of it, from the way it looked. That would strain supply lines and make it harder to operate behind enemy lines for any length of time. And the loud noise would alert everyone in the vicinity.

She still would like one. If it wasn't so damn loud.

"Oh, yes! Do you have a way to make more ammo?" Entrapta asked the others. "If you don't but have the formula and schematics for the bullets, I could make some for you."

And she'd also find out how to make the weapons herself. Catra smiled.

"Ah…" The woman looked to the older man.

“We’re still good,” he said. “But if we’re stuck here, we might want to talk to you about that.”

“Great! It’s like a completely new technology! There have been forays into kinetic weapons like this, based upon crossbows and bows, but crystal-based lasers and blasters were deemed more effective.”

“Probably because of the lessened strain on supply lines,” Catra suggested. And the lower chance of some idiot cadet blowing themselves and everyone else up by mistake.

“Yeah, lugging around ammunition can be a bother,” the old guy said with a shrug. “But we manage.”

“Crystal based lasers?” the woman - Carter - asked.

“Oh, yes. You use focus crystals to shoot laser beams. Not quite as effective as blasters, but if you have a power source, you can fire forever - or until it overheats and breaks down,” Entrapta explained. “Old technology. Blasters are more interesting.”

“I bet.” The old man chuckled. “But with the monster dead, and no loot I can see, how about we look for our way home?”

“Oh, yes! I already scanned the area here,” Entrapta told him. “No Naquadah, sorry!”

“Then let’s move on to the next area,” Glimmer said.

“Shouldn’t be too much left,” Bow said. “Unless there’s another level that we didn’t find yet.”

“I could run a seismic scan,” Entrapta offered. “Now that the worm is gone, I doubt that the sonic vibrations would attract another - they’re territorial, after all.”

“Do it,” Glimmer said. She sounded impatient. She probably wanted to get their visitors back to their planet or out of this facility.

Catra could understand the feeling. The group acted friendly, but they were dangerous. Their weapons might not be enough to hurt She-Ra, but everyone else wasn't nearly as tough. And those were just the weapons they had shown - who knew what else they had? You always kept something in reserve if you were a good officer, and the old guy didn't strike her as a bad officer.

No, he was like a tough, old Force Captain. If they came to blows, she'd take him out first. A decapitation strike. Perhaps literally - her claws would go through his uniform and throat, she was sure of that.

"Alright," Bow said, seemingly oblivious. "The next area is behind this junction ahead."

They went on, with Emily bringing up the rear. Catra wasn't too comfortable with the bot being their backup, but at least Emily wouldn't be easy to disable in case of an ambush - or treachery.

Though she had a feeling that the old guy already had plans for that. Several, probably.

To be fair, she was planning how to take them out as well. Just in case things turned sour, of course. And she was sure that Glimmer was also ready for a fight. Just in case.

*****

They were underground in a maze-like area fighting monsters looking for the key to getting home. It really felt like a roleplaying session. At least an old school one - Jack O'Neill wasn't quite sure if the hobby had changed in the twenty years since he had last played. Probably got too commercialised, like everything from the seventies.

He shook his head - he had to focus on the task at hand. He couldn't let himself get distracted by the absurdity of the whole thing - he had seen weirder, after all, since he started at SG-1. Though, given the talk about magic and space ships, Jack had a

feeling that things might get even weirder if they couldn't get the gate working and return to Earth.

Which, according to the science princess with the weird hair and weird name - Entrapta? Who named their kid that? - was looking quite unlikely.

"So, no Naquadah here either. Sorry!"

She sounded as if she was pleased about it. Then again, she was not quite normal. A little off, at least - even compared to her friends. Which included the catwoman who felt like a spook. The way Catra talked about gathering intel, and the way she kept an eye on Jack's team, always staying in the back if she could manage… If they came to blows, Jack would take her out first. She wasn't carrying a weapon, not openly, but that only meant that she had one hidden or didn't need one. With those claws of hers, Jack was betting on the latter.

"And I think that was the last part of the ruins we hadn't checked yet," Bow said. Did they name every kid after something obvious? Or did they earn their names once they came of age? Daniel would probably know that by now. But the kid looked apologetic. "I'm sorry, but I think this device you need isn't here. It might have been carried off since the installation was built."

"We might be able to build another one, though," Entrapta offered.

And find out how to operate the Stargates. Clever, Jack thought.

"It's a very complicated venture," Carter told her. "The Stargates need enormous amounts of power to work, and we need advanced computers that can interface with the gate. Most importantly, though, we need the gate addresses and astronomical data so the gate can correct for astronomical drift and safely connect to other gates."

"Oh, a nonstandard operating system!" Entrapta beamed. "Fascinating! I wonder if it's similar to Horde Prime's computers -

those were hard to fool!”

“Horde Prime?” Jack asked.

“The leader of the Horde that tried to conquer Etheria,” Catra told him. “We defeated him a while ago.”

That was valuable intel. “Sounds like a tough customer. Is he still around?” Jack asked, trying to sound only politely interested. It also sounded like a Goa’uld.

“No,” Catra told him.

“He was dealt with,” Glimmer added. No details, Jack noted. “But if you can’t return through the gate, we need to secure it and then return to Bright Moon.”

Her country. Or her something. With, presumably, more guards. “We can camp out here. We don’t want to be a bother,” Jack said. If Daniel were here, he would protest, of course, something about refusing hospitality, but Jack needed to know where they stood with the locals before trusting them.

“It’s the Whispering Woods - it’s full of monsters,” Glimmer told him.

“Like the worm?” Jack asked.

“Worse. How much ammunition do you carry for your weapons?” Catra asked.

Jack shrugged with deliberate nonchalance. “Enough to handle trouble.”

“Sir, it might be safer to accept their offer.”

Jack knew that as well. But now he knew that the kids hadn’t tried to order them to come back to their home. They had tried to persuade them. They might still order them, of course, if they

kept refusing. “Alright, I guess sleeping in a real bed wouldn’t hurt,” he said.

Catra snorted, but the others smiled.

“But we need to secure the gate,” Glimmer said. “We can’t leave it open for an invasion.”

“If we can move the gate, we can lay it down on the ground, facing up - anyone trying to exit would fall back down into the gate. Which, unfortunately, is fatal. The gates are one-way only,” Carter suggested.

Rather ruthless, but the odds of anyone from Earth following them and finding this gate were zero.

The kids, though, looked taken aback. Except for Catra.

“Can’t we… seal it so it doesn’t activate?” Bow asked, wincing. “You said we could, didn’t you?”

“Yes. We would have to bury it for that,” Carter replied. “It would need to be completely buried to keep it from activating - otherwise, it would blast an opening in whatever is covering it, unless you use a special metal.”

“Then let’s do that!” Glimmer announced. “We don’t want to kill innocent travellers.”

“It’s going to be a very deep hole. Unless you have explosives, that will take some time,” Jack explained.

Everyone smiled. “We don’t need explosives. We have She-Ra!” Glimmer announced.

“Although I could whip up some digging charges, I think,” Entrapta offered. “Though limiting their blasts so they create a hole instead of a crater would require some planning.”

“Let’s file that as Plan B,” Bow said, “and just ask Adora first.”

“Alright!” Entrapta nodded, apparently not fazed in the slightest.

They seemed to trust She-Ra - or Adora; She-Ra seemed to be her title - to be able to handle this. Jack was curious to find out if the woman could deliver. It wasn’t exactly easy to move a gate - you couldn’t just pick it up and carry it with you.

*****

“Where do you want it?” Adora asked, teeth clenched, as she turned with the Stargate in her hands. It wasn’t actually that heavy, but it was unwieldy - she had to hug the ring to herself, and she had to watch it so she didn’t swing it around too much and brain some of her friends or visitors with it. Or broke it by accident. And knowing that, should it activate right now, she might lose her arms… No, she wasn’t going to think about that!

“Just drop it on the ground to the side for now,” Entrapta told her, “Uh… this side - the right side up. No, the other right side, the left from your point of view - up.”

Adora suppressed the urge to curse and forced herself to smile as she flipped the gate over. “Like this?”

“Perfect!” Entrapta beamed at her. “Now, if the gate activates, it will blast a hole in the earth. Right?” She turned to face the blonde woman, Carter.

“Ah, yes,” Carter replied. She seemed still surprised that Adora had been able to carry the gate around. They must not have Minotaurs on Earth. Or Scorpionfolk. Compared to throwing a tank, the gate wasn’t exactly heavy. Then again, a tank could be replaced, but if Adora broke the gate…

“You must be popular when your friends are moving.” The old man, O’Neill, chuckled.

Adora blinked. “Moving? We’ve got a skiff for that.” Two actually - one for them, one for Entrapta and the camping gear. And Emily still had to walk.

“It’s a custom in our culture that when you change homes, your friends help you carry your furniture and other belongings to your new home,” Daniel explained.

“Ah.” Adora nodded. That made more sense.

“You don’t have porters?” Glimmer asked, cocking her head.

“We do, actually.” Daniel smiled at her. “But not everyone can afford them. Or trusts strangers to handle their most valuable belongings.”

“Ah.”

“Not everyone’s a princess,” Catra commented. “Some of us have to work for a living.”

Gimmer rolled her eyes. “You don’t work.”

“I do work. I keep you from killing yourself by being stupid, and I keep an eye on Adora, so you don’t make her do everything for you,” Catra shot back, showing her fangs.

Adora smiled - Catra was looking out for her, in her own way at least. But… “I’m currently doing all the work,” she pointed out.

“That’s because there aren’t any alternatives. We don’t have a troop of Glimmer’s guards here to carry the gate around,” Catra replied. “So, it’s you or nothing.”

“I would have brought some porters if I had known we would have to move anything,” Glimmer said.

“You expected us to find nothing in the ruins worth keeping?” Catra faked surprise.

“That’s not what I meant!”

Adora cleared her throat. They weren’t in private - they had visitors. Who were watching them attentively. “So, now we dig a

hole? Or, I dig a hole?”

“Like in training,” Catra said. “Just faster and deeper.”

“Training?” Daniel asked. “For… excavations?”

“Digging holes and trenches,” Adora corrected him. “Basic infantry training.”

“Oh.”

“They mentioned a war, Daniel.”

“Yes, Jack, but many societies do not have boot camp style training. At least not for their leaders. And while earthworks are a staple of warfare in history, they might not wage war in the same style here since the technology is wildly different. For example, a war fought on the sea would not see any need for sailors being able to throw up earthen fortifications - at least not so they would be trained for it.”

Catra rolled her eyes, Adora saw, as Daniel talked to his friends. The man had a tendency to go on for some time - but he had a nice voice and a friendly smile. Which probably was another reason for Catra’s attitude, Adora realised.

Well, that could be helped. Smiling, she walked over to her girlfriend and hugged her. Catra squirmed in her arms but didn’t actually try to slip out. “Love you,” Adora whispered - and her girlfriend froze for a moment.

“Not in front of the strangers,” Catra whispered back. But she didn’t really mean it. Adora could tell.

“So… hole?” Jack asked, cutting off his friend’s explanation. “I don’t want to rush anyone, but you mentioned monsters around here.”

“Right!” Adora released Catra and drew her sword.

“Are you going to dig with…” Jack trailed off when Adora changed the Sword of Protection into an oversized - for She-Ra - spade. “Now that’s handy.”

“A morphing weapon? A multi-purpose tool?” Carter shook her head. “Molecular reconstruction? It has to be to change like that, but as fast as it was...”

“Magic,” Entrapta told her. “We don’t actually know how it works - Castaspella said it wasn’t a spell, and she doesn’t know what it is, either, and she should know. It’s probably an innate talent of She-Ra. Like my hair is mine.”

Adora didn’t know how exactly it worked, either. But she knew how to make it work, which was all that was needed. She rammed the spade into the ground and started digging.

For all of Jack’s comments, he was correct - they shouldn’t linger here.

About fifteen minutes later, the hole was deep enough, according to Carter. And Jack had stopped making comments about excavators.

Then it was just a matter of lowering the gate down without breaking it - Carter said it wouldn’t break if dropped, but Adora wasn’t risking that - and filling the hole up again.

And then hiding the fact that they had dug a hole so no one would find the gate until they returned.

And then they were off to Bright Moon. Their visitors would love it there, Adora was sure.

*****

The Palace

Whispering Woods, Etheria, July 10th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Trying to disassemble the 'skiff' would be very rude, Samantha Carter told herself as she stared at the floating vehicle. It looked… like a cross between a sailing yacht and a… actually, it looked like a floating sailing yacht.

"We'll have to check if George Lucas is an alien once we return to Earth," the Colonel joked. "This looks almost like Jabba's skiff."

"Indeed," Teal'c said. "Although the skiff there doesn't have the sail."

"You've got skiffs as well?" Entrapta jumped down from her robot - Emily - and let her hair tendrils catch her fall. "How do they work? You said you don't use magic, so you can't be using a levitation spell stabilised in a crystal matrix like the skiff here does. Do you use gravity generators? The Horde tanks and frigates use them, but they're a bit bulky and finicky. Lots of maintenance is needed to keep them going at peak efficiency. Darla got a more robust system, but it's not as optimised."

"Darla?" Daniel asked before Sam could ask about the gravity generators - which had to be the same technology the Goa'uld used for their space ships' artificial gravity.

"That's our spaceship's name. I named her!" The princess nodded. "She's old but reliable, and I've been updating her systems for months!"

"Ah."

"But if you have a better way to create artificial gravity, I might use that. What do you use?"

"We were talking about a fictional vehicle," Daniel said. "We don't use anti-gravity vehicles on Earth."

“Oh. Is flying taboo in your world? If it is, we have a long walk before us.” Bow looked concerned. Judging by the way he winced, walking through the forest wouldn’t be a good idea.

“This is Etheria, not Earth. They’re guests here, not the other way around,” Catra snapped. “I’m not going to walk through the forest because someone thinks flying is evil.”

“No, we don’t have a taboo against flying,” the Colonel spoke up. “In fact, both Captain Carter and I are pilots.”

“Oh! Neat!” Entrapta gushed. “But you don’t use gravity generators or magic…” Her eyes widened. “Do you use pure powered flight using aerodynamic principles, like birds?”

“More or less,” Sam replied. “We have different ways to achieve lift.”

“And we can talk about all that once we’re underway,” Catra cut in. “I don’t want to be in the forest at dusk when all the worst monsters come out to hunt.”

“We were planning to camp here for a few days,” Glimmer said.

The catwoman glared at her. “That doesn’t mean we have to, now that we’ve explored the ruins. And that was just the five of us - I can’t protect everyone else when they’re stumbling around in the darkness.”

“Let’s just board the skiffs,” Adora said. “It’ll be a little tight, I think, but we’ll manage.”

“Can the skiff carry all of us?” Glimmer asked.

“No. At least two will have to ride with our supplies,” Catra said.

“Perhaps we should have taken a Hauler,” Adora said.

“A Horde Hauler wouldn’t have made it through the swamp,” Glimmer retorted.

“Emily made it.” Adora nodded at the robot.

“You carried her.”

“I could carry a Hauler,” Adora said.

Sam wondered what a Hauler was. The way they talked, it sounded like a truck - an all-terrain truck. But the woman claimed to be able to carry it. Then again, they had anti-gravity technology. And magic.

“Let’s just board the skiffs and get going,” Catra said again.

“We’d like to stay together,” the Colonel said.

Sam nodded in agreement. It was best to keep an eye on both Daniel and the Colonel.

“So… one of us needs to pilot the skiff, with four of you on board, it should work. The other skiff can carry three people, including the pilot, with our supplies” Entrapta said with a slight frown. “That means we’re one short. I can ride Emily!”

“Please don’t inconvenience yourself on our behalf,” Daniel said.

“It’s not an inconvenience. Emily’s my friend!”

“So, that’s settled. Let’s go already!”

“Catra! Don’t be rude!”

“I’m not being rude! I didn’t even call anyone names.”

“But they’re our guests!”

“They are also in the middle of the Whispering Woods.”

“It’s actually not in the middle,” Entrapta said. “We’re more to the east.”

"It's a figure of speech." Catra jumped up on the empty skiff in an impressive display of agility and strength. "I'm going to pilot this skiff," she said. "Everyone aboard!"

They climbed up the short ladder hanging down from the vehicle. There were no seats, Sam noticed. It really was like the vehicle from Star Wars. Not the most ergonomic design, she couldn't help thinking. But it flew.

"How high can this skiff fly?" the Colonel asked.

"Not very high," Catra replied as she looked at the other skiff. "The spell's only good for a few yards. Otherwise, we'd just break through the canopy and hightail it out of here."

Which was obvious in hindsight. Then again, nothing was obvious on a foreign planet.

"So… you're a pilot as well?" Daniel asked. As expected.

"Anyone can drive a skiff," Catra replied.

"Well, I can't." Daniel flashed her a smile. "But I take it skiffs are common, then. In our world, most people - at least in our country - stick to cars - but in another country, private planes are a common way to travel."

He was stretching the truth a little, there, Sam knew - not even in the outback in Australia were planes as common as cars. But it probably wouldn't hurt to make Earth appear a little less… earth-bound. They were dealing with what seemed to be a space-faring civilisation, after all.

And as much as she would deny it, should the Colonel ask, Sam was very curious how their settlements would look, with access to gravity generators and space ships.

*****

“So, do you do most of your trade with skiffs? Or are they just used for exploration and scouting?”

Didn’t the guy - Daniel - ever get tired of asking questions? “Both,” Catra told him.

“Ah.” He nodded, not looking confused or frustrated in the slightest.

“We were slower when traversing the swamp. Was that deliberately, or is this a limitation of the skiff?”

“The spell lifting us doesn’t work well over water,” Catra told the nosy woman.

“Like a hoverboard.” The old guy chuckled.

“A hoverboard?” Catra asked. The others looked confused, she noticed. Except for the tall, dark guy, Teal’c, but he never showed any emotion anyway.

“From Back to the Future,” O’Neill explained.

“Ah!” Daniel nodded with a smile.

Carter sighed while taking notes, so it was probably a joke.

Daniel cleared his throat. “It’s a, ah, fictive story in our world. Quite famous, actually, as far as such things go, and there’s a scene where the main character tries to use a hoverboard - a floating skateboard - to fly over a pond, and it stops moving.”

“Ah.” Catra nodded. “That’s the same here - the spell stops working, and the skiff goes into the water.” And then you better prayed that the hull had no holes in it.

She steered the skiff around a patch of forest, checking that Adora’s skiff and Emily could keep pace. Perhaps she shouldn’t have told their guests that - they might use that information if they stole one of the skiffs. On the other hand, it wasn’t really a

secret. Unless they locked the group up, they could easily find out how things worked. As they would easily find out about the war against the Horde.

And Catra had a feeling that Glimmer wouldn't have their guests locked up. Not on mere suspicion, at least.

"So, you use ships as well?" Daniel asked. "I mean, ships for the ocean, not space ships."

"Yes." Just because they could find out things didn't mean Catra had to spell out everything for them, though.

"Like Earth. Bulk trade is still most efficiently handled by ships," Daniel told her. "Do you have canals as well?"

"Some." No matter how curt she was, the guy didn't stop.

"So, do you have both an ocean port and a spaceport, or do the spaceships land in the water as well?" O'Neill asked.

"They can land in the water, but it's a little bothersome." There! Try to make sense of that!

"Do the spaceships use spells as well?" Carter had finished taking notes.

"Some do. Some don't."

That got a reaction - Carter exchanged a glance with O'Neill. Of course, they had no experience with magic, so they probably would feel safer in a Horde frigate.

Or they would feel safer stealing a Horde frigate. Catra pressed her lips together. If the Stargate wasn't working, a ship was their best bet to return to their home - Earth. She'd have to talk to Glimmer to ensure that their guests couldn't talk to the remaining Horde clones in Bright Moon. Not privately, at least. Most of the clones were still trying to adjust to a life not spent in blind obedience to Horde Prime. They weren't the brightest, either -

Before they had vanished, Double Trouble had said trying to con them was so easy, it was beneath the spy. Which was a good thing, or they would have probably gathered a following of their own by now.

"Did you ever talk to someone about what you did in the war?"

Catra's eyes widened at O'Neill's question. Why would he suddenly ask her that? What was his game? "Sometimes, all we did was talk about the war," she replied with a forced chuckle. "We had plenty of time in space." Not quite a lie. Not that she wanted to remember that time, on Darla, after Glimmer's rescue. After Adora had come for her, despite everything Catra had done.

"Ah." The old guy didn't pry. But he was looking at her in that weird way.

Catra almost sighed with relief when she finally spotted Bright Moon in the distance. "Look ahead!" She called out. "Bright Moon!"

They had caught it at the perfect moment. The sun was setting, but several moons were up already, and the town was shining compared to the darkening sky. The royal palace looming over the town was glinting, the golden wings catching the last rays of the sun.

"Wow!"

"Is that… an artificial waterfall? From the top of the mountain?"

"That, or their plumber messed up."

Catra snorted. Sometimes, the old guy was actually funny. "Don't let Glimmer hear that. It's her kingdom's pride and joy."

"What is that floating… crystal?"

Ah, damn. "That's the Runestone, the symbol of her rule," Catra said. "That's also her pride and joy."

"So, Jack, don't joke about it. There might be religious aspects as well to consider."

"Daniel, you know me - I'm the perfect diplomat."

Catra snorted again. But she actually didn't doubt the claim. She was sure O'Neill was the sneakiest of the whole group. The kind of guy who would sneak some bombs into a diplomatic meeting just in case.

Like herself.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, July 10th, 1998 (Earth Time)

So, that was Bright Moon. Shiny was an understatement, Jack O'Neill had to admit. The town was built around and into a steep mountain, domed houses circling the mountain's base and wrapping around its flanks as they snaked up to a huge palace. Compared to the settlements SG-1 had seen so far, it looked impressive. Very impressive. The artificial waterfalls - because there was no way a spring happened to be on the very top of a mountain, magic or no magic - would be the envy of a number of landscapers and architects on Earth. Mostly in Vegas, he thought with a chuckle. And the palace itself… well, the Goa'uld would like the golden statue on top of it. And the floating crystal. Very 'divine right'.

On the other hand, no Goa'uld would be caught traipsing through the jungle without an entourage large enough to serve every whim of theirs and build a road first. Or would ride with the luggage so their unwanted guests could take their seats on their floating barge. Jack had to give the locals props for that.

Then again, while their pilot had been quite curt and cagey when answering Carter and Daniel's questions, she had let slip enough - also by evading certain questions - to paint a pretty grim picture.

The kid had been fighting in that war they had mentioned for years. And, catwoman or not, if Catra or the other kids, with the exception of the hair princess, were a hair over twenty, Jack would eat his cap. Someone had sent those kids into war. And it had left scars. The way Catra didn't mention anything personal about the war, the way she got evasive whenever Carter or Daniel asked for details about this or that part related to the war… She didn't want to talk about it. Didn't want to think about it. Jack knew the signs. Saw them often enough in the mirror. And he had seen the signs on other kids, after the Gulf War. During his own mandatory therapy. It wasn't as if the US Army only sent adults into battle. But for the grunts, the ground part of the Gulf War had only lasted a couple of days.

Those kids here? They had fought for years. And Jack bet that they hadn't had an easy time of it. Which contrasted a lot with the shiny town they were approaching.

"That's… the architecture doesn't match any historical style," Daniel commented. "It must have evolved on its own. Another hint that this isn't a forgotten Goa'uld slave colony started with kidnapped people from Earth."

The fact that their pilot had cat ears, a tail, claws and cat eyes as well as fangs was a bigger clue, in Jack's opinion.

"Better keep that slavery stuff to yourself," Catra said. "Some people might take offence."

Such as the kid, Jack knew. The way she tensed… Had she gone through something similar as Jack had when he had been captured by the Iraqis? Or was he projecting? He couldn't check with the others right now. Not that he wanted to in the first place. He was their leader. They depended on him keeping things together.

"Of course. We meant no offence," Daniel said with an easy smile. "It's just that this is so fascinating!"

Catra snorted. “It came through the war quite well. Unlike other kingdoms, the Horde never took it. Came close a few times, though,” she added with a toothy grin. “The shield almost fell.”

She talked as if she were glad of that - did she resent the people here for staying safe while she was on the frontlines?

“The shield?” Carter asked.

“The magic shield protecting the town,” Catra replied with a scowl.

Another slip, then, Jack noted. The locals had force shields. Shields large enough to cover an entire town - including a mountain. SGC would want one of those. Or more.

They reached what probably passed for the gates for the city. It was a simple checkpoint. Jack could see two guards in ornate armour snapping to attention, spears raised. He tilted his head, but they were travelling a little too fast for him to make out whether or not the spears hid some blaster cannons. They probably did, though - the archer kid had trick arrows straight out of comic books, the sword of She-Ra could change into a spade, and the princess had magic hair. They couldn’t assume that any weapon they saw was what it looked like at first glance.

Hell, he thought with a snort, we better be careful with the cutlery, so we don’t accidentally blow up dinner.

They drove up a winding road towards the palace. A number of the people - both humans and aliens - on the street waved to the queen, but it was a far cry from the cheering section a Goa'uld fake god would have demanded. And some even glared at them. Trouble in paradise? Or some oppressed minority?

Jack couldn’t tell. But he trusted Daniel to have noticed it as well. And his friend would probably know what was up with that.

Then they reached the gates - massively oversized gates - of the palace. More guards snapped to attention, all in shiny armour with

capes. And Glimmer took charge. “General Juliet! We require quarters for four guests. And an escort for them.”

“Well, it’s not off to the dungeons with us,” Jack joked as he climbed down to the ground.

Catra snickered in return.

Jack had a feeling that he had missed something.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 10th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora shook her head. Catra was being rude. Well, ruder than she usually was. She could just be tired and cranky or there could be more to this. But this wasn’t the time to sort that out. “Don’t mind her,” she told their guests. “She just thinks it’s funny that the palace has no dungeons.”

“No dungeons?” Jack sounded almost disappointed.

“That’s not exactly abnormal,” Daniel said. “The White House doesn’t have any dungeons, either. There are prisons to hold, ah, prisoners. I suppose that things are the same here.” He looked at Catra, who snickered again.

“Not quite,” Adora’s lover said.

Glimmer sighed and rolled her eyes. “Bright Moon’s prisons aren’t rated for princesses and similar prisoners. So, when we had such prisoners, they were housed in specially reinforced rooms in the palace.” And where princesses were close to deal with any trouble, Adora knew.

“Which also were the guest quarters.” Catra grinned. “In other words, you’re going to the palace dungeons.”

“They’re not dungeons,” Glimmer spat.

“Could’ve fooled me.”

“You are welcome to find out the differences.”

Adora cleared her throat. “Anyway,” she said. “They’re really nice guest quarters.”

“Who can be turned into prison cells,” Jack said.

“Any room can be turned into a prison cell,” Entrapta pointed out. “A force field on the doors and windows is all you need. You can cover the walls as well if you think they could be breached.”

“And you did that with guest rooms for your prisoners?” Jack asked. “Not a storage room somewhere damp and cold?”

“We’re not the Horde!” Glimmer protested.

Catra scoffed. “Horde cells weren’t damp and cold.”

“But not as nice as our rooms.”

“Are you really arguing about who had the better dungeons?” Bow asked.

“No, they aren’t” Adora said, glaring at both of her friends. “So, let’s go?” She gestured at the open gates. “It’s getting a little late, and you probably want to freshen up before dinner.”

“Yes, thank you,” Daniel said with a smile. “That’s very generous.”

“It’s the least we can do,” Adora told him.

“Yes, yes, let’s go. I want to freshen up as well,” Catra said. “And you also need a shower.”

Adora frowned. She hadn’t really exerted herself, which was hard anyway as She-Ra, and she could simply change back and would be fine, but… Oh! “Yes, I do,” she said.

Glimmer rolled her eyes, but Bow elbowed her before she could say anything.

"Oh! You want to be intimate!" Entrapta beamed at them.

Adora forced herself to smile back while Catra snickered. "We want to rest a little."

"Ah!" Entrapta nodded and took out her recorder. "I see."

She would be recording another 'euphemism for sex'. But they got going. Juliet had a squad of guards show the others the guest quarters while Adora and her friends walked towards their own quarters.

As soon as they were out of earshot, Glimmer sighed. "Finally! What did you find out, Catra?"

"Not much," Catra replied. "They're good at hiding things. The old guy is the leader, but we knew that already."

Adora nodded. Their ranks had been obvious.

"But he's… laid back. Lets the others talk, Daniel and Carter," Catra went on. "They had a lot of questions," she added with a wry expression. "Anyway, he tries to play dumb but he's sharp."

"Well, he wouldn't be their leader if he were dumb," Adora said.

"Anyway," Catra said, "He's got training in interrogation, I think. The way he looked at me when he thought I wouldn't notice, and how he commented on some of the questions…" She hissed under her breath. "I think he's the most dangerous. Most experienced. He's not a scientist like Carter or Daniel is, but..." She shrugged. "Just a feeling I got off him, and Melog agrees."

Adora nodded. That fit her own impression. "What about Teal'c?"

"Didn't say more than a few words." Catra cocked her head. "Melog says he's intense. Whatever that means."

“And Carter is a great scientist!” Entrapta blurted out. “I’m looking forward to sharing data with her! The things we could research together!”

“Ah…” Adora licked her lips.

“Perhaps we should wait a bit before we share data?” Bow suggested. “We don’t know them yet.”

“The best way to get to know someone is data.”

“That doesn’t mean we need to give them data,” Catra said. “They’re already gathering intel.”

“Daniel had got a lot of questions,” Adora agreed.

“About what?” Glimmer asked.

“Everything,” Adora told her. “From clothes to families to religion.”

“Oh, yes. The guy never stops talking.” Catra sighed. “I was tempted to crash the skiff just to shut him up.”

Adora hoped she was joking.

Glimmer frowned. “Do you think they’re spies?”

“No,” Adora said.

“Yes,” Catra said.

“What?” She stared at her lover.

Catra shrugged. “I don’t know if they are here to spy on us. But they’re spies. Scouts. Whatever. So, don’t transform around them. Not until we know more about them, and whether we can trust them.”

“Great.” Glimmer slumped a little. “Another problem to deal with.”

“It’s not a problem - it’s an opportunity! A network of Stargates!” Entrapta gushed. “Imagine how many worlds we can visit!”

“Or how many worlds can be invaded,” Glimmer retorted, tilting her head. “You heard about those Goa’uld. And what they do.”

Adora suppressed a shudder. Snakes that wrapped around your spine and took over your body? They were worse than Horde Prime. She glanced at Catra. Her lover had her arms crossed, claws denting her own skin - she must be remembering being chipped.

Adora wrapped her in a hug, feeling her tense for a second before huffing and relaxing. And then she started squirming since they were still in public, sort of, and Adora let her go.

“We need a way to detect those snakes. Other than Melog,” Glimmer said while Catra huffed and ran a hand through her hair.

“I bet Carter and the others know one!” Entrapta was still smiling. “Another reason to share data.”

Glimmer didn’t look like she agreed. Adora wasn’t sure herself. Daniel was nice. And the others seemed, well, not bad either. And yet… They had to talk about this.

*****

The quarters they were shown were very much unlike cells. Samantha Carter didn’t remember ever staying in more luxurious surroundings - they might put the best hotels on Earth to shame.

“A waterfall inside the room? Those interior decorators would make a killing in Vegas,” the Colonel commented as he walked around. “Although their beds need some work,” he added, pressing a hand down on the mattress. “That’s more like an oversized pillow than a mattress. You could drown in this.”

Teal’c nodded. “Indeed. I will sleep on the floor.”

The Colonel looked at her. “Any bugs, Carter?”

She shook her head. “None that I can detect.” That didn’t mean much, of course. The locals could be using entirely different technology to do their surveillance. Or just have a person with their ear pressed to the wall. But they had to discuss their situation - they couldn’t wait much longer.

“Well, maybe there is a kernel of truth in the tale of the Princess and the Pea,” Daniel said, chuckling. “But I’m sure we can ask for harder mattresses. Our hosts seem very accommodating.”

“Yeah, ‘seem’,” the Colonel told him with a frown. “Don’t let the glitz and pastel fool you. Those people have been through a war. At least the ones in charge. A bloody war.”

Teal’c nodded in agreement. “They are veteran warriors, not untried children.”

Sam nodded as well. They were correct. The way the group reacted to threats… They were acting like soldiers, not archaeologists. Certainly not like young adults on an ‘adventure’. And the little details that Entrapta let slip about her technology… “Yes, sir. And they grew up during the war.”

“That will have shaped their lives and outlook, yes,” Daniel said. “But many aristocratic societies hold guest rights in high regard. I doubt that they plan to turn on us.”

The Colonel snorted. “It’s an alien society with magic princesses and animal people, Daniel. Who knows how they think?”

“They aren’t animal people!” Daniel protested. “They are humanoids with some animal traits.”

And clearly human or ancient ancestry in the mix. Sam wished she had a way to test the DNA.

The Colonel mumbled something that probably involved potatoes. Sam ignored it. “And they are technologically advanced. Entrapta

knows more about robotics than anyone on Earth, sir."

"So, you believe their claim that they have spaceships, Carter?"

"Yes, sir." She nodded firmly.

"Why would they make this up?" Daniel asked. "They didn't know us. Or about us."

"Or they want us to think that," the Colonel pointed out.

"I doubt that. I talked at length with Adora. And we talked with Catra. Their stories match up. And how could they have expected us? They would have had to improvise a deception that holds up under scrutiny without being able to coordinate their answers." Daniel shook his head.

"They could be talking in their minds," the Colonel retorted. "Or like the cat. The four-legged cat."

Sam couldn't discard that possibility, but she didn't think that was likely. "I believe they were genuine."

"Maybe they were, but that was out in the woods. Now we're in a palace. A royal Palace."

"We haven't met many democratic societies, Jack," Daniel said. "And with obvious magic talents present in some locals, apparently hereditary, an aristocracy is a logical result."

"An aristocracy that just finished a war involving spaceships. And with huge guns." The Colonel shook his head. "And ground soldiers that can carry Stargates around as if they were bags of groceries. We aren't in Kansas any more for sure."

Sam smiled at the reference. "And we don't have any red shoes."

The Colonel chuckled. "So… were guests of magic princesses. And we need to find a way to activate the Stargate to return to Earth. Ideas?"

"We need to find the D.H.D.," Sam replied at once. "It's the fastest way to restore the gate's functionality. Entrapta can scan for Naquadah, so if she's able to build a scanner with enough range, we should have good odds of finding the missing D.H.D."

"If it's still around, you mean."

Sam pressed her lips together. If the D.H.D. wasn't around any more… She nodded. "If we cannot find it, we might be able to build a computer and power source for the ring. Entrapta's work with robots and artificial intelligence clearly shows that this civilisation has the resources to build both supercomputers able to handle the load as well as the power sources to supply the gate." As long as Entrapta's claims were true. But the princess hadn't seemed to be lying. And Sam doubted that the others would have gone on an expedition with a delusional person - they had trusted Entrapta and treated her as an expert on technology.

"How long would that take?"

"That's hard to say, sir," Sam ventured. "But months at least. It depends on the architecture. I will have to program the software as well. And the navigational data."

The Colonel didn't like that, judging by his frown. But it couldn't be changed. "So we will have to live in Barbie's Disney Palace for a while."

Daniel nodded with a smile. "Their civilisation is fascinating. We've barely scratched the surface. Different species! Multiple sapient species! Spaceships and magic! And a society shaped by both, possibly founded by the Ancients!

Well, at least one of them was happy about their situation. Though if Sam was honest with herself, then she had to admit that she was looking forward to studying the local technology as well. Including the magic parts.

*****

“We should have made Entrapta build a device to eavesdrop on our guests without them knowing,” Catra said, looking at the ceiling above their bed.

“Hm?”

Catra felt Adora shift next to her. The arm she was resting her head on pulled a little to the side. She resisted the urge to grab it and let her claws prick the skin to keep it in place. This wasn’t the time for games. They’d already had their fun, anyway. “I’m sure they’re planning something. We should listen in.”

“That would be rude.”

“So?” Catra turned her head. Adora was frowning at her in that pouty way that made her so… She smiled against her will, and Adora smiled back.

But then she grew serious. “You don’t eavesdrop on your guests.”

How naive. Catra wanted to shake her head. “You eavesdrop on potential enemies.” That was the smart thing to do.

“They aren’t our enemies. And they’re just four people.”

“Four people can do a lot,” Catra pointed out. Like the ‘Best Friends Squad’, as Bow insisted on calling their group. Even though it now included her. And she was many things, but not a good friend, much less the best.

“They’re not princesses,” Adora retorted. “They don’t have any magic. Their weapons aren’t anything special, either.”

“Entrapta would disagree.” As would Catra. The rate of fire she had seen put laser rifles to shame.

“That’s because the weapons are different. But they aren’t really better than Horde small arms.” Adora shook her head. “I’d rather have a stun baton. It’s more versatile.”

Indeed. The ‘Tau’ri’ must not take many prisoners with their weapons. “The baton has a shitty range, though.” The stun setting only worked in close quarters, and the blast setting wasn’t much better. ‘Just far enough so the blast won’t hurt you’, they had called it in the Horde.

“Well, that’s what laser rifles are for. And those don’t need ammunition.”

“But they run out of power.” Catra smiled. Talking about weapons… that took her back to when both of them had been little, just starting weapons training as… cadets. She stopped smiling.

“Eventually.” Adora blinked, then bit her lower lip. She had noticed Catra’s mood. Somehow, she always seemed to notice. Or almost always. It was both annoying and, well… endearing. “It’s OK,” Adora said in a softer voice.

Catra rolled her eyes and huffed. They didn’t have to talk about that. “We shouldn’t underestimate them. Carter’s like their Entrapta.” And they both knew how dangerous Entrapta was if she put her mind to it. Or when she didn’t really think about what she was doing.

“Do you really think they are here to hurt us?” Adora shifted to her side. She let her arm keep serving as a headrest for Catra, though.

Catra scoffed. She didn’t really think that. But... “We can’t exclude the possibility. Even if they arrived here by accident, they are a potential threat. If their enemies follow them and think we’re allied with them...”

“Well, they are our guests. And those Goa’uld sound horrible. Almost as terrible as Horde Prime,” Adora pointed out.

“We only have their word for that,” Catra retorted. She wasn’t going to think about being brainwashed and controlled, a prisoner in her own body.

“And Melog doesn’t like the Goa’uld,” Adora said.

Melog confirmed that with a slight growl from their bed.

“That doesn’t mean our guests are nice, though.” She held up a hand to stop Adora’s response. “They seem nice - but Double Trouble also seemed nice.” Before they stabbed her in the back.

“Double Trouble is…” Adora trailed off before she could embarrass herself by calling the spy ‘nice’. “...special,” she finished with a frown.

Catra snorted. “Speaking of them, we really should track them down.”

“Why?”

“I don’t trust them.” Catra scowled. “And not just because of what they did to me. Do you trust them, with so many lost Horde Clones around with no idea what they should do now?”

“Do you really think they’ll try to take over a group of clones?” Adora shook her head. “They’d grow bored of it in a heartbeat.”

That was true, and Catra believed their claims about that. “I’m more concerned with them causing trouble.”

“We can deal with that if it happens.”

“When it happens,” Catra corrected her.

Adora smiled wryly. “When then.”

She should take this more seriously, in Catra’s opinion. Horde Prime’s flagship and many of its escorts around Etheria had been dealt with, but there were a lot of Horde ships left, both over Etheria and in the rest of the former Horde realm. “Well, when Double Trouble takes your appearance and starts another She-Ra cult amongst the clones, you can deal with it.” Catra showed her teeth at her lover.

Adora grimaced. “Ugh. The first was bad enough, and they started that on their own.” She blinked. “Unless… Do you think that was Double Trouble?”

“No.” The spy would have told them. Double Trouble was sly, but they craved attention. And they bragged all the time so people would know how ‘smart and creative’ they were.

Adora sighed. “Anyway, I don’t think our guests are a threat to us.”

“I’m still going to keep an eye on them,” Catra said.

“That’s OK. Trust but verify, right?”

Catra scoffed. “Someone has to keep the lot of you from falling for every scam. Might as well be me.”

“Yes.” Adora smiled at her, then leaned over and kissed her.

If they had a little more time… But dinner would start in half an hour. Just enough to get another shower and get ready.

Catra sighed as she returned the kiss.

*****

For a royal dinner with the Queen of the realm - and her father, the king - this was a rather casual, private affair, Jack O’Neill thought as he looked around. Less than a dozen people, all in all, sitting at a round table that would have had him make a King Arthur joke if anyone other than his own team would have understood it. Two guards at the door, and Jack hadn’t seen more than three different waiters so far.

He had been at working dinners at the Pentagon that had been more formal and more grand affairs. Of course, that probably said more about the Pentagon than about their hosts here. Still, he was positively surprised by the lack of pomp and circuses. And relieved - you could always count on Goa’uld to go all-out with the

boasting and posturing. Though the furniture and the cutlery were all of the finest quality, as far as he could tell - he was no expert.

“Do you like the meal, Colonel?”

That was the king. Though, as far as Jack had understood Daniel’s explanation, he was actually the former queen’s consort. Glimmer was the actual ruler of this realm. “It’s excellent,” he replied. “Your highness,” he added. It was actually very good. And not too exotic, either - a tasty steak, just as he liked it, with some vegetables that looked like broccoli but tasted not unlike carrots.

“I’ll tell the cook,” the king said, smiling. Really down to earth, Jack couldn’t help thinking. Much more polite than most brass he had met back home. Also a far cry from most politicians he had met.

“It’s excellent, your highness,” Daniel chimed in. “May I ask what it is called?”

“Uh, steak with greens,” the king replied. “Beef, in this case.”

Daniel actually looked surprised and a little disappointed. Jack smirked - his friend probably had hoped for some exotic dish steeped in myth and history.

“You can also use horse meat for it, but that has fallen out of favour since the war,” Entrapta said, looking up for a moment from where she was talking to Carter in a low but excited voice. Voices, actually - Jack had the feeling that he should be concerned about that.

“Oh?” Daniel turned towards her.

Jack tilted his head slightly. Had they had a shortage of beef during the war and had to turn to horses? Jack knew that many countries in Europe had to order rationing during the Great War and World War II and had to make do with alternatives for traditional dishes. Horse meat would have been an obvious choice to replace beef.

"Yes," Adora said. "Swift Wind put an end to butchering horses." She looked up for a moment, then down again, and Catra, sitting next to her, snickered while the blonde woman flushed.

They had animal activists here? That was a surprise. Daniel would probably say this was another sign of an advanced civilisation.

Glimmer cleared her throat with a slight frown. "He did. I trust the guest quarters are to your satisfaction, Colonel?"

"They are," Jack replied. "Although the beds are a little too soft."

"Jack!" Daniel hissed. "You can't just complain about…"

But both Adora and Catra laughed. "Oh, did you get the standard beds? Yes, far too soft," Catra said.

"I almost drowned in them the first time I slept in the palace," Adora added.

Queen Glimmer pressed her lips together for a moment. "I'll tell the staff to replace the beds with the Horde model," she said.

"It's not actually a Horde bed or cot," Bow said, leaning forward. "It's what we call the beds that visitors from the former Horde are more comfortable in."

That was interesting. So, they had visitors from their enemies? Former enemies?

"We'd never have guests sleep on horde cots or bunks," Adora said, shaking her head. "Unless they insisted, of course. But the Horde models are much more comfortable without being too soft."

And that was interesting as well. It almost sounded as if she was very familiar with the difference.

"You said former Horde," Daniel spoke up. "What happened to the Horde?"

“Scorpia changed the name after the war,” Adora said.

“She restored the Scorpion Kingdom,” Glimmer said.

‘Scorpia’ and ‘Scorpion Kingdom’? A former princess who managed to reconquer her country?

“Well, she’s working on that - most of the land is still wilderness thanks to Adora, but they are making progress in turning it into fields,” Entrapta said with a slight pout. “I offered to construct bots to clear the plants, but Perfuma said she could handle it.” Then she perked up. “But once they rebuild their industry, I’ll get to design the new factories so they won’t pollute the environment! I’ve got so many ideas, and Hordak knows what went wrong the first time, so this will be so much fun!”

Adora was looking down at her plate again. What had she done to the land? Jack wondered. Some weapon of mass destruction? Or a bombing campaign? It had to be something horrible for her to feel so bad about it. But Glimmer was scowling, he noted. As was the king. Jack was missing something here.

“Hordak?” Daniel asked.

“Hordak! My partner!” Entrapta beamed at him.

“Yes.” Glimmer definitely didn’t like that, Jack noted. “But enough of that,” she went on. “Could you tell us of your home, Colonel?”

They were constantly deferring to him, Jack noted, when addressing SG-1. And calling him by his rank. So, a certain formality persisted. Or were they just treating him like a royal? If Daniel made a ‘Princess Jack’ joke… He shrugged. “There’s not much to tell. We’re from Earth. It’s quite the normal planet - we work, we farm - I like to fish in my spare time. It’s very relaxing even if you don’t catch any. Of course, that’s because where I like to fish, we don’t have such monsters as we met in the Whispering Forest.” He smiled his best ‘harmless retiree’ smile at them.

“And you have a Stargate to travel to other worlds,” Glimmer went on. “Which you use extensively, despite the obvious dangers.”

Of course they wouldn’t just accept his deflection. He kept smiling. “We discovered the Stargate a while ago. When we opened it, we encountered the Goa’uld. They want to conquer us, but we’ve held them at bay ever since, but that means we have to be active.”

“If they need gates to attack, that shouldn’t be too hard,” Catra remarked. “Unless they have spaceships.”

Jack kept his polite smile on even though she had just named SGC’s worst fear - an invasion with a fleet of big honking spaceships. They had barely defeated an invasion by two Goa’uld motherships. “We keep them busy in their own realm. Saving slaves, striking at their armies, the works,” he said.

“And exploring new worlds,” Daniel added. “We’re always looking for allies against the Goa’uld.”

Jack suppressed a wince. Daniel was showing their hand far too soon. He was usually much more diplomatic.

“And you hope to have found some here,” Glimmer said in a very neutral voice.

“Well, your cat knows about them and how bad they are,” Jack pointed out, nodding at their big alien cat, which was lounging on the floor near Catra. Perhaps he could salvage this.

“Melog does, yes,” Catra said. “But they’re not eager to start another war. They’re the last of their species - they were all killed in the last war.”

Daniel winced. And Jack wanted to sigh - they had stepped into it there.

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The Dinner Conversation

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 10th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"The last of their species?"

Their guests sounded horrified, Adora noticed. As they should be, she thought a moment later, feeling guilty at her grief surprise. Wiping out entire planets was one of the most horrible things you could imagine. Unless you were Horde Prime.

"Yes, Horde Prime razed their planet when they resisted his attack," Glimmer said.

Adora kept her expression neutral while she nodded. "And it wasn't the only planet that suffered that fate."

"Sounds like he took lessons from the Goa'uld," O'Neill commented. "They're big on making examples out of any resistance as well."

"Yes," Daniel agreed. "They would eradicate a planet's population, then resettle it with slaves if they deemed that necessary to crush a rebellion. Sometimes, they even rendered the planet barren, unable to sustain human life. They mark such planets with a totem to warn off Jaffa and others."

That sounded terrible as well. But then, they were fighting the Goa'uld, and it was obvious that they wanted help. Yet, fighting another war...

Melog growled.

Catra nodded. "Horde Prime did the same - he wiped out the planet."

"Yes. There actually wasn't much left that could sustain any life on Melog's home planet," Entrapta said. "The ecosystem was

completely destroyed. I don't think it could've been restored without magic - or technology on a scale we don't have access to."

"It's an example to discourage the others," O'Neill said. "Tyrants generally think nothing of sacrificing one world to control the rest."

"It wasn't the only world," Adora told them. "The Star Siblings were the only survivors of their people as well. Horde Prime did that to many, many worlds."

"Oh." Even O'Neill looked taken aback.

They still didn't understand. "He didn't want to rule the population. Just as long as they were useful. Ultimately, he wanted to replace them with his clones," she said. "Clones who were utterly loyal to him. His perfect empire."

"He had a collection of art and food from the various planets he had destroyed," Glimmer said. "He liked to show it off."

Adora glanced at Catra. Her friend was tense, sitting utterly still, but her tail was rapidly swishing back and forth. She placed her hand on Catra's thigh and gently squeezed.

"Well, I think no one will be missing the guy," O'Neill said.

"Except for his clones," Entrapta corrected him. "They're very lost without him. Left adrift. Some even died because they didn't bother eating."

Adora clenched her teeth. She hadn't had any choice - she had to destroy Horde Prime before he destroyed Etheria and everything else in the sector. But the clones, brainwashed to blindly obey, were suffering because of it. And there wasn't much she could do about it - they didn't even know where most of them were, what with Horde Prime's flagship gone. Turned into plants. All they could do was helping those on Etheria and nearby to rebuild their lives.

"Well, enough of that," Micah said. "You were telling us about your world, Colonel."

"Ah, right." O'Neill's smile was fake; even Adora could tell. But he nodded. "Well, as I said, it's a rather average world. We've got a lot of water - about two-thirds of the planet's covered in it. Lots of people, too, but there are still plenty of places where you can be by yourself and relax."

And they still called the world 'Earth' even though it was more water than earth? Well, different planet, different customs. "That sounds peaceful," Adora commented. Far more peaceful than she would expect of a world fighting such monsters as the Goa'uld.

"Well, I won't say we don't have any conflicts," O'Neill said. "But most people are just living their lives. And they won't have to face war if we've got anything to say about it."

"Until the Goa'uld reach your world with their spaceships, you mean," Catra said. "Pretty hard to live your life once the orbital bombardment starts and the infantry and tanks drop into your towns."

"They probably would get stuck in traffic," O'Neill said with a short snort.

"Sir," Carter hissed.

"Sorry, that was a bad joke about traffic jams in big cities." The man's smile looked a little rueful.

"Trying to move anything through a bottleneck is frustrating," Catra said. "One stuck transport and an entire column might be forced to divert - or wait for supplies."

"Yes. That can be averted with proper planning, though, and a smart traffic control system," Entrapta cut in. "Not that it's needed any more, what with the Horde dissolved. But it would have worked if I could've implemented it."

Adora liked Entrapta very much, but sometimes, she wished her friend would not sound quite so disappointed about all the missed opportunities to make the Horde even more dangerous.

"So, tell me about your leader," Glimmer said. "Who rules your world - or your country, if you aren't a united world. You don't seem to have monarchs, do you?"

Adora leaned forward. This was interesting.

"Ah, no, most countries elect their leaders," O'Neill said. "Everyone gets to vote for who calls the shots."

Adora blinked. That was… "How does that work?" she asked. "You just… gather and say who you want to lead you?" That might work for a village, but for a town like Bright Moon? "And how do you pick whoever you want? Do you see their test results?"

"Test results?" Now O'Neill looked confused.

"How else do you know if your pick for leader is a good leader?" Adora explained. "Do you look at how they fared in leadership training?" That was how Force Captains had been selected, at least as far as she knew.

"Most people chosen as leaders have some experience with leadership on a smaller scale," Daniel said.

"Ah. So, like promotions," Catra said. "You look at who's doing well leading a squad, then promote them to lead a platoon, and if they don't get everyone killed, they take over the company once a slot opens. Sensible." She nodded.

Daniel cleared his throat. "Ah, it's not quite like that."

"I sure hope it isn't," Glimmer muttered. "Just because you can lead troops doesn't mean you can rule a country."

"Well, you would know best," Catra told her with a smile.

Adora winced.

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Samantha Carter saw the queen glare at Catra for that flippant comment. And the smile looked quite toothy. Did that mean that the queen had started commanding troops and wasn't very adept at ruling the country? Well, she was very young, so she obviously couldn't have a lot of experience. Although her father would be helping her with advice and, possibly, handling some matters himself.

Daniel cleared his throat again. "There are no restrictions for running for, ah, leadership positions, although there is usually a minimum age requirement. In our country, for example, you have to be thirty-five years old to become president - which is the highest office, the leader of our country."

"Wow, Frosta would hate that!" Entrapta said next to Sam. The princess turned towards her. "She was always sensitive about her young age," she whispered.

Sam blinked. Young age? Glimmer, Queen Glimmer, looked as if she were barely in her twenties. "How young was she when she took her throne?" Sam whispered while Daniel went into a brief or not so brief explanation of various age requirements."

"I think she was eight years old when she took over the throne of the Kingdom of Snows."

"Eight years old?" Sam blurted out, a little too loudly, as it turned out since everyone looked at her.

"Talking about Frosta?" Catra asked.

"Yes." Entrapta nodded.

"You had an eight-year-old ruler?" The Colonel shook his head.

"I'm sure she had advisers," Daniel was quick to say.

"I think she had," Entrapta replied with a nod. "It's not as if you can run a kingdom, even one as small as Dryl, on your own. Although I probably could if I used my bots, though they are kind of like advisors. Or guards. Or servants. But I don't call them that, or my actual servants might feel hurt."

"Our monarchies - many of them, at least - had a regent when the heir to the throne wasn't of age yet. The regent ruled until the monarch reached adultness." Daniel smiled at their hosts.

"But you replaced them with your elections, didn't you?" Catra asked.

"Well, yes," Daniel admitted. "Though in some countries, the monarchs remained as heads of state, though with very limited power."

"So… you have countries with a queen or king and an elected leader," Glimmer summed up. "What if they don't agree on something?"

Sam winced. That was a tricky question, and…

...Daniel answered it honestly: "The elected government takes precedence."

Sam was very relieved that the Colonel didn't make a guillotine joke.

Catra snorted. "Well, that only works if your princes and princesses don't have any magic powers."

"I think that is the crucial difference between our two worlds, yes," Daniel agreed. "Without, ah, royalty defined by magic powers, a king or queen's right to rule was more easily questioned. In the past, they claimed divine right to rule, but there came a time when that, too, was questioned - as was religion itself. So, gradually or abruptly, most monarchies were replaced by democracies. Democracy means 'the rule of the people'."

“Government of the people, by the people, for the people,” the Colonel quoted Lincoln.

It was quite clear, at least to Sam, that their hosts didn’t like that. Well, except for Entrapta, who seemed intrigued. Then again, the princess seemed to be curious about everything from Earth.

“Fascinating!” she gushed. “So, you elect your leader, who then acts like a princess without magic.”

“And you hope you didn’t pick an idiot as your leader,” Catra added. “If you did, how do you get rid of them? Kill them off?” She actually sounded serious, Sam noticed.

“There are regular elections,” Daniel explained. “Usually every four to seven years. But in most democracies, there’s generally a non-violent way to remove a particularly inept leader. A peaceful change of power is the hallmark of a working democracy.”

“And if that doesn’t work?” Glimmer asked.

“Then you tend to have a violent change of power,” the Colonel said.

“But that’s rare in democracies,” Daniel quickly added. “The most stable countries in our world are democracies.”

“Fascinating!” Entrapta beamed. “So, you use a system of calculated instability - the change in government based on elections - to create long-term stability. A very creative concept with a number of promising applications.”

That was a rather creative view, but not wrong. Though Sam had a feeling that Entrapta was thinking about something not related to government.

“That’s about it,” Daniel said, nodding.

“And how can you make long-term plans if you will be replaced in a few years?” Glimmer asked.

"Well, in most countries, you can get reelected. Some countries have term limits, but they vary." Daniel nodded. "But there are some issues with short-sighted policies."

"I bet," Catra said. "That's like letting the troopers run the army."

"Oh, I've met some troopers who would be great at that," the Colonel said. "And some generals who were bad at running anything."

"Must be a bad system then," Catra retorted. "If you end up with bad leaders at the top."

"And you would know all about that, wouldn't you?" Glimmer asked with a toothy smile.

Sam frowned. She was missing something here.

*****

Catra glared at Glimmer then forced herself to smile. Good hit, Sparkles - though she had still copied Catra. And she wasn't entirely wrong. Catra had messed up. A lot. Of course, she had also won a lot. Conquered Plumeria and Salineas. Almost taken Bright Moon. All without some sparkly magic power or sparkly magic friends. All without Adora…

A hand - Adora's - squeezed her knee. "No system is perfect," her lover said, frowning at Glimmer.

"No one's perfect," Catra whispered under her breath. Adora sometimes still thought she had to be perfect.

"Yes!" Entrapta, with perfect timing, piped up. "It's how a system deals with the inevitable errors that crop up that determines if it's a good, working system or a problem. Also, blowing up is generally not a good result." She nodded.

Catra snorted, even though she was pretty sure that Entrapta was talking literally about blowing up. But it fit anyway. Or either way,

given what Glimmer and she had done in the past.

Adora nodded, but before she could say something, the old guy spoke up. “And those officers were removed, retired, or moved to a post where they couldn’t do much harm. Eventually.”

Oh, that was a pretty soft system then. Inept leaders would’ve been disposed of in the Horde. Or sent on a suicide mission to the Crimson Waste, she reminded herself. “So, your troopers got promoted to replace them?” she asked.

“Some,” O’Neill replied. “They would have to want to get promoted - and they would have to go to officer’s school.”

“Officer school? Is that like the cadet command course?” Adora asked. “Where you learn how to lead?”

“Pretty much, yes,” O’Neill told her. “Though you don’t really learn to lead - that you only learn in the field through experience.”

Which was true. And sometimes, you didn’t learn how to really lead, even if it seemed to be working. But that wasn’t the subject Catra wanted to hear about. “So, you either replaced your princesses, or you turned them into servants?”

“Ah, not servants. That wouldn’t be correct,” Daniel spoke up. “They serve the state, but as Head of state, performing ceremonial and representative duties. And while they generally don’t have any, ah, official power, they still have a lot of soft power - influence amongst the people and the politicians, that is, the elected officials in the government and parliament.”

Still sounded like a raw deal for any princess, in Catra’s opinion. Not that some of them didn’t deserve to be replaced or serve someone, at least for a while. Teach them how everyone else lived. As Adora showed, you didn’t need to rule a country to be a princess, anyway. Some would probably be happier if they didn’t have to deal with a country.

Glimmer, though, wouldn't. She was keeping up a polite front, but Catra could tell that she didn't like what she was hearing. "But how were your original monarchs chosen if you didn't have any magic?"

"Mostly by their ancestors killing everyone who disagreed with the opinion that they should lead," O'Neill replied.

"Jack!" Daniel glared at him. "That's an oversimplification. While probably true in some cases, not every leader was selected through force of arms. As experiments and records show, often, leaders were chosen for their qualities in handling a crisis."

"So… you first elected your leaders, then they stopped being elected, and now you're back to electing them?" Micah asked.

Daniel laughed. "You could put it that way, I suppose, though, as usual, the truth is more complicated."

It always was, Catra knew. Nothing was ever simple. If it looked simple, it was a trap. And their guests did look a little too simple for her taste. A team of soldiers, here by accident, fighting enemies that fought Melog's people in the past and were a threat to Etheria. Very simple, very convenient.

"So, who's your leader?" Glimmer asked.

"Ah, do you mean our country's leader or our commanding officer?" Daniel asked,

"Both."

Catra leaned forward. This would be interesting.

"Stargate Command is under the, ah, command of General Hammond," Daniel said. "He's an experienced officer who has seen us through a lot of situations. And he cares for the troops under his command."

“He’s a fine, honourable leader,” the tall, dark and silent guy, Teal’c, spoke up.

“Yes.” Daniel nodded.

So, basically, ‘good officer’. Not much to go on.

“And your country’s leader?”

“That would be the President. He’s in his second term,” Daniel said. “He’s done a lot for the economy; the country’s prospering.”

“Impressive,” Glimmer commented. “A country generally suffers in a war.”

“Unless you’re winning and conquering enemy territory and resources.” Catra looked at their guests. Fortunately, Glimmer didn’t take this as a dig but as the warning that it was meant to be.

“Ah, we don’t conquer territory. We’re looking for allies, actually,” Daniel said. “But since we mainly fight the war through the Stargates with limited means, we didn’t have to turn the economy into a war economy. Most people don’t even know about the war.”

Catra blinked. That sounded… “You’re fighting body-snatching snakes out to destroy your planet, and you haven’t geared up for war?” That couldn’t be true!

But from the way the others, especially O’Neill, frowned at Daniel, it probably was true.

What were those people thinking? That wasn’t how you won a war!

*****

Just great. Daniel kept spilling intel. And in the worst way possible. Jack O’Neill knew that being honest with potential allies was the best policy - keeping secrets tended to come back and

bite you at the worst possible moment - but there was a time and place to explain how SGC operated and the first dinner date with royalty wasn't it.

But it would have to be. He had to fix this before their hosts got the wrong impression. He shook his head. "We're doing what we can. Since we fight this war through the Stargates, we don't exactly need huge armies, and tanks and planes wouldn't fit through it." Theoretically, a tank would fit, but that would require ramps that could handle its weight - and you'd have to get the tank to the gate in the first place. Not to mention that Death Gliders would turn most tanks into scrap in short order.

"Planes?" Adora asked.

"Vehicles that rely on aerodynamics to generate lift to fly, not spells or gravity generators," Entrapta explained.

"Yeah, that," Jack said. "Anyway, vehicles are generally too big to send through the gate - at least military ones - and we aren't invading any planet anyway, so we're using small, mobile teams to explore, recon and strike."

"Like your team?" Catra asked.

"Yes." That should be obvious, in Jack's opinion.

"Great. You're fighting princess-style without princesses." Catra snorted. "And you're doing it using natural choke points."

"We're not walking through the gate without sending in a drone first," Carter said.

"Unless we have to leave in a hurry," Jack added. They were already aware of that, after all.

"It's still…" Catra shook her head. "How can you fight a war without even telling your people?"

Jack shrugged. “We manage.” It wasn’t the best idea, in his opinion, and he absolutely hated lying to the families of the soldiers killed in action about accidents instead of telling them the truth, but orders were orders, and those came from the President himself. And Jack had done enough black ops to know that the military refusing to obey the government was a bad idea. Generally, at least - sometimes, you had to do what you had to, orders or not orders. But he certainly wouldn’t bitch to strangers about that. “It also keeps us under the radar. If the Goa’uld saw us sending armies through the gate, they might stop fighting each other and unite against us.” And Earth would be conquered. Hell, just one System Lord with a single spaceship could crush all their defences unless SGC managed to pull off another miracle.

“But how can you prepare to repel an invasion without telling your people what’s happening?” Glimmer asked.

That was a question Jack had asked himself. “We’re doing what we can - recruiting the best and brightest, gathering information, looking for weaknesses…”

The others didn’t look as if they were buying that. Well, from what they had said and let slip, they had been through a more conventional war. As conventional a war could be when they were using magic, of course. And spaceships.

“That only works until the other side changes the rules,” Catra said. “If you rely on the gate protecting you, you might end up like Salineas.”

“Salineas?” Jack asked. He saw that Catra flinched a little, and the blonde, Adora, pat her hand.

“A kingdom in the sea, protected by the Sea Gate,” Adora explained. “The Horde found a way around it and attacked with massed forces. It fell quickly.”

“Ah.” The catwoman had probably fought there. He nodded at her. Losing a battle was always hard.

“But why are you looking for allies if you don’t even use your own people?” Glimmer asked. “That sounds as if you want others to fight your war.” She narrowed her eyes at them. “And why should we trust you if you don’t even trust your own people to tell them the truth?”

Damn. Well, time to do what Daniel would do. “To be honest,” Jack said, “Earth isn’t as advanced as the Goa’uld. We can match them on the ground - we’re a bit better, actually, since our weapons are more effective - but we don’t have spaceships or the technology to produce them.” He ignored Carter’s slight gasp. “Not yet. So, even if we went all war economy, we would only produce more targets on the ground which would be bombed from orbit. We stopped one such invasion, but if they launch another, we’re pretty much done for.” He pressed his lips together. He didn’t like admitting how weak Earth was, but they weren’t dealing with a planet full of slaves or former slaves, kept at a primitive tech level for millennia. These people had spaceships.

And they looked surprised. Jack could tell as they exchanged glances and looks.

“And if we told everyone, there would be a mass panic,” Daniel spoke up. “People would riot, wars might get started - we’re not ready for such a revelation. We would have to prepare for that very carefully, or we might destroy ourselves before the Goa’uld make another attempt to take Earth.” He smiled ruefully. “We only started using the Stargate a few years ago.”

“In other words, you’re desperate,” Catra said.

“We’ll help you!” Adora blurted out. “We won’t let another planet be destroyed.”

Jack blinked. He hadn’t expected that. Judging by the groans of Glimmer and Catra, they hadn’t expected that, either.

*****

Catra was giving her that look - the one where she thought Adora was being stupid - again. And Glimmer looked annoyed with her. If both of them agreed on something.. Well, they were still wrong this time! Adora sat straighter. “We’ve seen what happens when people like Horde Prime aren’t stopped. He destroyed a lot of planets just for not bowing to him. If the Goa’uld are the same, then we have to stop them.”

Melog growled. It sounded like they approved.

Catra sighed. “Melog agrees,” she confirmed.

Adora smiled at both of them.

Catra still glared at her. Same as Glimmer.

“Thank you!” Daniel beamed at her.

“Yes, thank you,” O’Neill added. “So what would that help entail, exactly?”

Oops. Adora had spoken as if she spoke for everyone. No wonder Glimmer was annoyed. “Well, I’m She-Ra. I’m good at destroying spaceships.” She smiled at the Tau’ri.

“Well, that’s straightforward.” O’Neill sounded as if he was sarcastic, though.

“Just point her at a spaceship you don’t like and let her at it,” Catra said. “But we’re not going to let her go off alone.”

“Of course not,” Glimmer said with a last glance-glare at Adora before looking at O’Neill. “But we’re not going to rush out without a plan, either.”

Adora hadn’t been planning to do that! She was about to point that out when Catra’s hand on her thigh - the claws pricking her skin - stopped her.

“If we are to become allies, we need a lot more information about your world,” Glimmer went on. “What kind of help you need, what kind of help you can provide.”

“Data!” Entrapta said, nodding. “The more data, the better. We can’t make plans without sufficient data. First, we need to determine where Earth is in relation to us. Then we can work out how long it’ll take for a fleet to arrive here.”

“A fleet?” O’Neill tilted his head a little.

“I think we’ll need a fleet. But without more data, I can’t say how big it has to be,” Entrapta said.

“We’ll also have to ensure that Etheria is safe from any attack by the Goa’uld,” Catra pointed out. “That means enough ships to stall an invasion force and a secure Stargate so we can return at once if Adora’s needed.”

Glimmer nodded after a glance at Catra. “You have the means to secure a Stargate and still allow easy access through it,” she told their guests. “We need that.”

“That requires quite the resources,” Carter said.

“Which we’ll gladly share,” O’Neill cut in. “No sweat.” He looked at Carter and mouthed something Adora didn’t catch.

“Yes!” Entrapta beamed. “We need metallurgy data and examples of the mechanism you use.”

“And we need to talk to your leaders,” Glimmer said. “So we can come to an agreement. We’re not going to jump into a war without a formal alliance.”

Right. Politics. Adora wasn’t good at those. She wasn’t a real princess, after all - she was the protector of Etheria, not a ruler. She nodded anyway.

“That can be arranged,” O’Neill said.

“With all your leaders, though. Not just your country’s,” Glimmer told him. “We aren’t going to create another Horde.”

“What do you mean?” Daniel asked.

“When Hordak arrived on Etheria,” Glimmer explained, “He was alone. He created the Horde by using his knowledge to take over the Scorpion Kingdom, which he then turned into the core of his army - an army dangerous enough to almost conquer Etheria.”

“Wait!” Daniel said, frowning, “You mentioned Hordak before.” He looked at Entrapta.

“Oh, yes. He’s my science buddy.” Entrapta smiled, then blinked. “Ah, yes, he doesn’t want to conquer Etheria any more, don’t worry!”

Adora didn’t need to hear Glimmer’s words to know that her friend was muttering ‘he better not’ or something like it under her breath.

But their guests looked surprised. “Hordak was the leader of the Horde?” Daniel asked.

“Until he turned against Horde Prime,” Entrapta confirmed. “And he only led the Horde he had built on Etheria, not Horde Prime’s Horde.”

“He turned against his cruel leader,” Teal’c spoke up with a slow nod. “An honourable action.”

“Yeah, yeah.” Glimmer’s mouth twisted into a slight grimace. “It was pretty much everyone against Horde Prime.”

“We have a saying on Earth: The enemy of my enemy is my friend,” Daniel said.

“Something like that,” Glimmer said.

Adora half-expected Bow to mention the Best Friends Squad, but he stayed quiet.

“Yes,” Entrapta nodded with a scowl. “Horde Prime wiped his memories - or tried to. Hordak was stronger than he thought, tough.”

“Not all of us are best friends,” Bow spoke up, “but we aren’t enemies any more.” There he was!

Adora nodded in agreement. “Yes. We all worked together to defeat Horde Prime. And we’ll have to work together to defeat those Goa’uld.”

“Well, we have sort of experience with that,” O’Neill said, looking at Teal’c. “Working against your former overlord and such.”

“Indeed. It’s our hope that many more Jaffa will turn against the false gods.”

Right. Teal’c had changed sides as well. Adora remembered his comments.

“So, with that settled, we have to determine where Earth is, so we can get there. We probably can find a world with a Stargate to travel there, but that won’t work for spaceships.” Entrapta nodded. “Do you have any astronomical data?” she asked, beaming at Carter.

*****

“So… that went…” The Colonel trailed off after closing the door to their quarters.

“I think it went well,” Daniel said with a smile. “We made new allies.”

Samantha Carter suppressed a wince. They might have made new allies, allies with advanced technology - very interesting

technology, as she had gathered from her talk with Entrapta - but...

"Care to tell me why you kept spilling information about Earth to people we just met?" the Colonel asked, narrowing his eyes.

Daniel, unlike what Sam had expected, wasn't flustered. "It was necessary to earn their trust, Jack," he replied, crossing his arms over his chest. "Lying to them would have caused trouble as soon as the truth came out."

"You didn't have to lie," the Colonel told him with a frown. "But you didn't have to tell them everything."

"Lying by omission is still lying," Daniel countered. He was frowning - digging in his heels, Sam realised. "We're dealing with an advanced civilisation here, Jack! Not with former slaves hiding from their 'gods'. They just finished a decades-long war, too. Do you think they wouldn't have noticed if I answered evasively? They did actually, but were too polite to point it out."

Some of their hosts had noticed when Daniel had been evasive, Sam agreed. But Entrapta probably had missed it. The woman was brilliant, but she seemed to have some issues with social interaction.

"They were so polite, they called us desperate and started to list conditions for their help."

"Aren't we desperate?" Daniel retorted. "We barely managed to defeat Apophis when he arrived with two motherships. If he returns with an actual fleet…"

The Colonel clenched his teeth. "I'm aware of our military situation, Daniel. But everything has its price. The more they know about us, the more they can demand."

Daniel shook his head. "They won't do that, Jack. They're good people."

The Colonel snorted. Sam was forced to agree with him - Daniel was naive. Their hosts might be good people - they certainly have that impression - but they were also rulers of a country. And that meant they had to act in the interest of their country.

Their friend looked at them and frowned. “I’ve talked to Adora while you were hunting monster worms. She’s not going to extort us. And she won’t let others extort us either.” He sounded convinced of that.

The Colonel scoffed. “She also wants to bring magic to Earth.”

“And she probably could,” Daniel retorted. “At least something she considers magic.”

“A form of energy you can manipulate, according to Entrapta,” Sam said, “if you have the talent for it. Probably a genetic condition or trigger.”

“That’s not the point.” The Colonel shook his head. “I didn’t get the impression that she would be asking nicely if she could turn Earth into a land of magic and rainbows.”

Sam was, once again, forced to agree with this assessment.

“She won’t. Just as she won’t let us get exploited.” Daniel shook his head as well. “Jack, this is the chance we’ve been hoping for! Allies who have the technology and means to fight the Goa’uld on even terms! And they have magic!”

“So they claim.”

Sam cleared her throat. “So far, their claims seem to be plausible, sir. I’ve talked with Entrapta, and she has demonstrated a quite extensive knowledge of Ancients technology.”

“Don’t let the spears and swords fool you,” Daniel added. “They have shown us their technology.”

“We didn’t see their ships,” the Colonel objected.

“Why would they lie about that? What would they gain?”

“Entrapta knows how to navigate in space,” Sam pointed out. The woman had asked for astronomical data, and Sam didn’t doubt that, if she had enough data, she could locate Earth.

“And she wants to know where Earth is.” The Colonel clenched his teeth. “We can block the gate. We can’t block space.”

“Do you expect them to invade us?”

“We’ve only met half a dozen people here,” the Colonel pointed out. “What about the rest of the world? And they’re working with their former enemies!”

“That fits with their society, Jack.” Daniel smiled. “In an aristocratic society, people often felt closer to fellow aristocrats than to their subjects, even if they had fought each other in the past. Especially if they hadn’t lost close family in the war. They might not have the concept of nationalism as we know it.”

“They fought a war against the Horde - and it was a total war; you saw their reaction when they found out that the USA doesn’t run a war economy.” The Colonel shook his head once more. “And they let the enemy leader off.”

“That wasn’t uncommon on Earth, either. Especially for aristocracies. And he switched sides according to them. You can’t judge them according to our values, Jack. And they aren’t like the Goa’uld.”

“We hope so.”

“We have seen their reaction to the Goa’uld practices and policies,” Sam said.

“They do not seem as if they would tolerate the false gods,” Teal’c commented.

“And it’s not as if the USA is only allied with perfect democracies,” Daniel pointed out - a little snidely, Sam thought. “At the very least, they do not seem to discriminate based on gender or sexual orientation.”

“There were a lot of women in charge and few men,” Jack objected.

Sam refrained from rolling her eyes. “They accepted you as our leader at once, sir,” she said. “If they were biased against men, they wouldn’t have done that. They would have kept looking to me instead. Trust me, sir, I would know.” She had experienced enough discrimination and sexism in her career to spot that kind of bullshit everywhere.

The Colonel looked a little abashed but wasn’t giving in. “So they aren’t a matriarchy,” he said. “But they aren’t a democracy, either. And we don’t know how they will react if and when they visit Earth.”

Sam had to agree again. They could only hope for the best now.

*****

Catra shook her head as she leaned against the planning table in Glimmer’s operation room - which wasn’t called that, of course, but something like ‘planning room’. Or ‘Royal Planning Room’, all capitals. “So… we’re going to help those guys just based on their word alone?”

“Melog confirmed their claims about the Goa’uld,” Bow pointed out.

“Yes, yes.” Catra waved her hand. “But just because their enemies are as bad as they say doesn’t mean our guests are as good as they say.”

“Do you think Daniel lied?” Adora asked. She wasn’t fidgeting, but she sounded a little insecure. Damn.

“I don’t think so,” Catra admitted. “But he wasn’t telling us everything.”

“And the others didn’t like him telling us as much as he did,” Glimmer added. “We did hear enough, though.”

“We did? We still don’t have astronomical data to locate their home planet. Or the location of another Stargate,” Entrapta said.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes for a moment. “We know enough to make a few deductions.”

“As Mermista would say,” Adora cut in with a grin.

“And me too! It’s science!”

Glimmer’s eyes narrowed further. Sparkles didn’t like it when she was interrupted, Catra knew that. “First, they are not representing their world, but a single kingdom.”

“But they don’t call it a kingdom,” Bow cut in.

“I was coming to that.” Glimmer glared at him. “Second, they don’t have kingdoms. They have no princesses in charge.”

“Some of their countries might be ruled by royalty,” Catra pointed out. Daniel had been a little evasive.

“But none that matter,” Glimmer said.

Bow cleared his throat. “Since they don’t have magic, it’s understandable that they don’t have royal lines.”

“Third,” Glimmer continued a little more loudly, “they don’t like our plan to return magic to their world.”

“Sam likes it, I think,” Entrapta said. “She was very interested in my data on magic.”

“O’Neill doesn’t like it.” Glimmer objected. “And he’s their commander.”

“Yeah,” Catra agreed. “But he doesn’t like many things, I think.” He reminded her of some older Force Captains she knew. Had known.

“That doesn’t change that we have to help them.” Adora took a step forward. “We can’t let their planet get destroyed. Or any planet.”

“Yes.” Glimmer smiled. “And we will help them. But we can’t just blindly stumble into this. We don’t want to cause another Horde situation.”

“Do you really think they’ll use our help to conquer their world?” Adora asked.

“They aren’t their kingdom’s leader - they answer to them,” Catra pointed out.

“But we wouldn’t let them use us to conquer anything.” Her lover shook her head. “We’re not the Horde.”

“If they learn magic here, then they will be ready when we return magic to their world. That would give them a huge advantage,” Glimmer said.

“If their world works like ours.” Bow looked at them. “We don’t know that.”

“Magic is an advantage,” Catra told him. “Without it, the Horde would have crushed you.”

“But as the Horde proved, you don’t need magic to win a war against a kingdom with magic,” Entrapta spoke up. “Although since the Horde ultimately lost, that might be incorrect.”

“In any case, we need to know more before we can commit to an alliance.” Glimmer put both hands on the table.

“I won’t let their planet get destroyed!” Adora insisted.

“And we won’t,” Glimmer agreed. “But that’s not the same as forming an alliance.”

“Right.” Catra nodded. “Since they need protection we can station a fleet in their system. That would give the clones here something to do.”

“Some people are nervous about the presence of the clones,” Bow said. “But should we send them out to fight a war on someone else’s behalf?”

Catra grinned. “If She-Ra is going, half of them are going anyway.”

Adora frowned at her in return. “I don’t want them to! I am no goddess!”

Catra shrugged. “You killed their god, you took his place.”

“Hordak killed Horde Prime!”

“Hordak wasn’t the one to turn Prime’s flagship into a plant. A space plant,” Catra shot back. “They pray to you, not to him.”

“Well, some do,” Entrapta said. “But not all. Some do want Hordak to lead them.”

“What?” Glimmer all but jumped.

“He refused - it’s tedious, he said. And he’s right. But just as we have a responsibility towards our kingdom - you taught me that, remember? - he has a responsibility for them.” Entrapta beamed at Glimmer.

Catra kept a smile on her face, but she was a little worried. Hordak working with Entrapta was one thing. Hordak working with clones? Clones with space ships only they and a handful of people on Etheria, most of them in this room, could fly? That was another thing.

“Why didn’t we hear of that?” Glimmer asked.

“Well, nothing happened. There was nothing to tell,” Entrapta said. “You don’t want to hear about our failed experiments, do you? If you do, I can fetch my log!”

Glimmer grimaced. “No, that’ll be OK.”

“I do,” Bow said.

“Oh, I’ll get it to you later. Look it over? You might spot things we missed.”

“Sure.”

“Thank you!”

“Can we get back to the whole new war thing?” Glimmer asked. “We need to decide what to do.”

“We need more data. About everything,” Entrapta said. “I think we need to finish upgrading Darla and then go looking for Earth or a planet with a Stargate. Although we need to fly to Earth anyway if we want to protect it.”

“And we need to find out what we are facing - how many ships the Goa’uld have. Where they are. And how we can beat them,” Catra added. “How many ships we need to protect Etheria. And how to use the Stargate network.”

“Oh! If we get access to the entire network, that will make it easy to return magic to everyone!” Entrapta smiled. “Just walk through the gate, do your magic, then go to the next planet!”

Adora perked up. “Right!”

Catra was both relieved and annoyed. It was nice to know there was a more efficient alternative to flying through space from planet to planet. But Adora was still set on returning magic to all

the planets without it - no matter how long it took. As if it was her fault what the First Ones had done.

Well, at least she wasn't planning to sacrifice her own life and happiness for it. That Catra wouldn't let her do. And as long as she was with Adora, it would be alright.

"So… we need to talk to them some more," she said. "Sound them out. And find out where Earth is."

Which was still a stupid name for a planet. Might as well call it 'dirt'.

*****

The Third Fleet

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

He was getting old, Jack O'Neill thought as he got out of the still too soft bed. His back ached in a familiar way, just in different spots. A few stretches, though, and it was gone. "Rise and shine, sleepyheads!" he said.

Daniel grumbled something from where he was half-buried into his pillow, but Carter got out of bed. Jack carefully didn't watch her as she stretched in her tank top and shorts. She was his subordinate; nothing could come of anything he wasn't thinking of, anyway.

Teal'c rose from his meditation - his kelno'reem. Not that Jack saw any difference to normal meditation.

"You have the bathroom, Carter," he said. She wouldn't take as long as Daniel, and the three men could share. That it would also mean Carter wouldn't wait in her sleepwear was just a bonus.

She nodded and went into the way too luxurious bath. Whatever their hosts were, they were rich. Well, this was a royal palace. Jack had been in dirt-poor countries where most people lived in huts while their leaders lived in palaces with fleets of luxury limousines. At least the people in the streets hadn't looked like they were starving.

Daniel yawned and groped for his glasses with one hand. Jack was tempted to pull the glasses away before his friend found them, but such pranks were something you did at home base, not in the field.

"I wish I had such a bed back at Stargate Command," Daniel said as he put the glasses on his nose and got up.

“I believe similar beds are readily available for you,” Teal’c told him, “according to the advertising I saw.”

“I didn’t mean at my home, Teal’c. I meant at my lab.”

“Daniel, if we gave you a comfortable bed, you’d never leave the base,” Jack told him with a grin.

“Well…” Daniel grinned. “It would be worth it. It’s not as if I have much of a social life, anyway.” And there vanished the grin. He was thinking of his wife again. Sha’re. Who had been snaked.

Jack clenched his teeth, then forced himself to relax. No point in dwelling on that. They were still in the field. Stranded on an alien planet with potential allies. This wasn’t the time or place to deal with those issues. “Well, I’ll ask the general once we’re back. But a bed of this size will mean you won’t have much space left for your artefacts.”

Daniel actually took his joke seriously for a second - he frowned before he pouted. “Very funny, Jack.”

Jack chuckled. “Anyway, I’m not sure the United States Air Force will pay for a palace. We don’t have the budget for it.”

Daniel laughed at that and got up, rolling his shoulders. “Well, I’ll just have to enjoy our stay here, then.”

“Yeah, with our friendly royalty,” Jack muttered before he could help himself.

And Daniel frowned at him. Damn. “Jack. This planet has a completely different culture and history. We can’t judge them according to our own standards.”

“Sure we can. We do the same to the Goa’uld.”

“That’s different,” Daniel shook his head. “These people don’t keep slaves. And they’re willing to help us, even though they’ve just fought a war. You can’t compare them to the Goa’uld!”

"It is not a fair comparison," Teal'c added.

Damn. "I didn't mean that they are like the Goa'uld. But I've heard 'It's another culture' before, and it generally meant that we were meant to look away when our 'allies' did something that would get them jailed in the US."

"Just as they were told to tolerate things from you that would get them jailed in their country, right?"

That was normal - the US didn't let other countries judge their soldiers. "Don't tell me that you'd prefer living under an absolute monarch instead of in a democracy," Jack said.

"I don't!" Daniel protested. "But we can't expect democracy to evolve on a planet where magic is real, and royalty has magic powers. The social dynamics are completely different."

"Just because it's logical doesn't make it right," Jack countered. "Might doesn't make right." He pressed his lips together - he knew better than most that in many places, you had no rights without might or support from the mighty. But this was more fundamental. "We don't let just soldiers vote. Or the rich."

"Not any more. But we used to. In Athens and other Greek democracies, only men could vote."

"That still doesn't mean that it's right."

"It doesn't, but we can't expect them to follow our customs," Daniel said.

"And what if they expect us to follow theirs?" Their hosts were young, after all, and convinced they knew best. "They're planning to turn Earth into a magical realm."

"Even if they manage that, that doesn't mean they'll manage to change your society. We're too advanced to revert to feudalism."

Jack hoped that his friend was right. But before he could make another point, Carter stepped into the room again. In uniform, but…

"What did you do to your hair?" Daniel asked.

Jack nodded - it looked different. Still regulation-length, but… more like a style worn by a fashion model than a soldier. Not like Carter's usual style.

Carter frowned. "I just washed it with the shampoo that was in the bathroom. That was all. When I was done, it looked like this."

"Magic hair shampoo. Now I've seen everything." Jack shook his head. He wouldn't use the shampoo. "Tell me if your hair starts moving on its own, Carter."

"Sir!"

*****

Jack O'Neill hadn't seen everything. Not by far. Standing on the perfect green grass in the palace courtyard, he was forced to admit that.

"Did someone say Swift Wind?"

Swift Wind wasn't an animal activist. He was a horse. A talking, flying horse. With a horn on his head.

"Swift Wind, these are our guests: Jack O'Neill, Daniel Jackson - they're not related. Samantha Carter and Teal'c," Adora said. "Everyone, this is my friend Swift Wind!"

"Your friend and loyal steed, united by a bond no one else shares!" The horse raised one hoof into the air and looked at the sky.

A talking, boasting and posing horse. They really weren't in Kansas any more. Or Jack had gone crazy and no one had told

him.

“It’s like the Pegasus!” Daniel whispered. Ok, Jack hadn’t gone crazy.

“Actually, it’s an alicorn,” Carter corrected him.

“What?” Jack turned to her.

“It’s from a cartoon show I had to watch when I was babysitting as a teenager. A winged unicorn is an alicorn,” Carter explained, blushing slightly.

“You’ve seen horses like Swift Wind before?” Adora leaned in towards them.

The horse, too, perked up. “Oh, I thought I was the only one - created by She-Ra’s magic, but if there are others of my kind…”

Carter shook her head. “No, no, it was just… fiction. Tales of imaginary creatures.”

“Well, I’m anything but imaginary, I’ll have you know.” The horse threw his head back and flared his wings.

And he had been created by She-Ra’s magic? Jack shook his head. “If you can do this on Earth, you’ll be revered as a goddess by every teenage girl in the US.”

He saw Adora grimace at that.

*****

“I don’t want to be revered!” Adora blurted out. “I’m no goddess!” The clones turning to her were bad enough! She didn’t want more such people following her!

“We know,” Catra said. “You snore too much for that!”

Adora shot her a glare. “This isn’t the time to joke! I really don’t want any more followers!”

"Ah… I was joking," O'Neill said, looking puzzled. "You wouldn't really be revered as a goddess on Earth. Not literally, at least."

Adora smiled at him. That was such a relief!

Then Daniel cleared his throat. "Uh… I don't want to pry, but… did this happen before? You seemed to take this seriously."

Adora winced. "Well, the Horde clones - the clones of Horde Prime. Some of them consider me a goddess."

"'Some'." Catra snorted.

Adora glared at her again. Hadn't they agreed that they wouldn't spill more 'sensitive information' to their guests until they knew more about them and their goals? That was the reason she was always She-Ra when meeting them!

"Why would they revere you as a goddess?" Daniel asked. He tilted his head in apparent confusion.

"Well…" Adora smiled at him, though she knew it wouldn't look convincing. "They think that I killed Horde Prime, and he was the centre of their lives. So, they replaced him with me." And she couldn't tell them to get lost - who knew what they would do then?

Daniel still looked puzzled. "Well, it's not unheard of in mythology that someone took the place of a god by killing them, but… why wouldn't they take your word that you aren't a goddess?"

"Religious zealots wouldn't even listen to their god if he told them they were wrong," O'Neill said. "They'd tell him he was wrong. Or convince themselves that they heard wrong."

Daniel frowned at him. "Jack! This is obviously a serious problem! And since the Goa'uld are posing as gods, knowing more about this might give us some insight into how we can convince more of their slaves that they aren't gods."

“Indeed,” Teal’c agreed.

“Especially since you didn’t even kill Horde Prime. Who spread that narrative?” Daniel asked.

“Ah…” Adora bit her lower lip. How could she explain the whole situation without revealing more than she should? She had killed Horde Prime, kind of, after all. But not by herself.

“Oh, She-Ra broke his power and turned his flagship into a space plant!” Swift Wind said, throwing his head back. “And then she turned the stinky barren Fright Zone into a lush country covered with fields and forests! Perfect for grazing! It was glorious!”

Right. Adora winced again while Catra pressed a hand to her face, and Glimmer glared at Swift Wind. They hadn’t briefed her friend about the need for more discretion.

“You turned his flagship into a plant?” Carter sounded… well, as if she didn’t believe them. And slightly shocked.

“Well… I was channelling the magic of the Heart of Etheria, and, well, it had to go somewhere…” Adora spread her hands.

“A space plant,” O’Neill repeated in a flat voice.

He didn’t believe her, either, Adora realised. She frowned. It was embarrassing, but she was telling them the truth!

“Yeah,” Catra spoke up. “If you watch the sky, you can catch a glimpse - it’s still orbiting Etheria. And we call it a space plant since, apparently, it’s still looking healthy despite months in orbit.”

“But… the radiation, the vacuum, the temperature differences in space…” Carter shook her head. “That’s…”

“Yeah, that’s She-Ra for you,” Catra said. “She doesn’t do things by half.”

“The magic did it!” Adora protested. She’d only had vague intentions to render the ships harmless. She hadn’t planned to turn them into a giant plants!

“It does sound a little…” Daniel trailed off, grimacing.

“Well, we can show you,” Adora said before she could help herself. “Darla should be able to make orbit in no time. Entrapta probably would like to give it a test ride - she’s been tinkering with her.”

“That’s not necessary. We were merely surprised - plants don’t survive in space where we are from.” Daniel smiled at her.

“No, no, I insist,” Adora told him.

“And don’t worry, Darla hasn’t crashed since her original crash, even when she had all those problems with the systems,” Swift Wind added.

“Her original crash?” Carter asked.

“We recovered her wreck and restored it,” Catra told the woman. “She lasted a thousand years buried in sand, so she won’t break down on the next flight.”

Their guests nodded at that.

“I’ll call Entrapta,” Bow said. “We can go over to where Darla’s parked.”

“Turning barren land into fertile meadows and turning weapons into plants… that certainly would be grounds for deification in our myths,” Daniel said as they started walking towards the back of the palace, where Darla was parked in an enclosed courtyard.

“Swords to ploughshares, space edition.” O’Neill snorted.

He didn’t believe her. Even Adora could see that.

Well, he’d see.

They entered the courtyard. Darla was there, and Entrapta was working on the left engine - Adora saw her legs dangling out of the opening.

"That's certainly not a Goa'uld inspired craft," Daniel said. "And it's a thousand years old, you said?"

"At least," Adora told him. This had been Mara's spaceship.

"But it's holding up nicely - the First Ones technology is very durable," Entrapta cut in as she jumped down, her hair catching her fall. "And I've fixed the fluctuations in the engine thrust! She's all ready and eager for a trip to space!"

*****

Daniel was right, Samantha Carter knew. This ship wasn't a Goa'uld design. She couldn't see any parallels. Other than the ramp at the stern, but that was just good design. And the size of the engines… She craned her head to take a closer look at them.

"She's old but tough. And I've been upgrading her!" Entrapta said next to her. "She's now faster than a Horde frigate!"

Sam had no idea how fast a Horde frigate was. But she nodded anyway.

"And I strengthened her shields. They're not as strong as a frigate's, of course, but Darla's far smaller and more manoeuvrable, so she can avoid fire."

"Up to a point," Bow commented, looking at the engine as well. "Did you add the booster?"

"No. It, uh, kinda had some tiny problems at sustained use," Entrapta told him. "But we'll get around to fixing that as soon as the lab's fixed. Incidentally, did you know that boosters can explode like a bomb?"

Sam winced at that. As did Bow.

Entrapta went on: “I mean, it’s kinda obvious, if you think about it, since they enhance the energy output of a device…” She blinked. “Oh! We need to test that with Naquadah! Once we have some.”

“Uh…” Bow looked at her, Sam realised. “That metal amplifies explosions, right?”

“Yes.” Sam nodded.

“So it should amplify an engine as well - it’s just energy, after all!” Entrapta nodded.

“But if anything explodes with it nearby…” Bow trailed off.

Entrapta blinked again. “Oh, right. We have to be extra careful with that. Once we get more of it. Though I guess a few samples should be possible…”

“I don’t think you should try to take a sample from the Stargate,” Sam told her. “That could affect its function.” And, depending on the method used - it wasn’t easy to get a sample of Naquadah from a Stargate - could cause more trouble.

“Oh, right. Well, once I’ve finished building a global scanner for it, we can search for deposits from space!”

“Is this ship armed?” the Colonel asked.

“Yes,” Entrapta replied.

“Not really,” Catra said. “Just two blaster cannons.”

“Technically, that’s armed. We took them from tanks!”

“So, this is a civilian vessel?” Daniel asked.

“Uh…” Entrapta cocked her head. “She’s She-Ra’s vessel.”

“She’s not a warship,” Catra said. “But she’s fought in the war.”

That seemed to be good enough for Daniel.

“She belonged to my predecessor,” Adora told them. “Mara.”

“Did she crash her?” the Colonel asked.

Hadn’t the ship been buried for a thousand years in sand? Did that mean the last She-Ra had been a thousand years ago? Or… Sam almost bit her lip at the thought. How long did Adora or Mara live? The group here looked young and acted as you’d expect a bunch of people their apparent age would act after fighting a war - Sam was familiar with soldiers of their apparent age - but if they were actually far older… She would have to ask Daniel about that. He was their expert on alien cultures. Sam focused on technology.

And the ship was a marvel of technology, Sam had to admit as they entered. Very spacious - not at all like the ships she was familiar with.

“Darla’s not quite up to greeting us,” Entrapta explained. “I’m still working on a holographic display for her.”

“She’s intelligent?” Daniel asked.

“She’s smart,” Entrapta replied. “But she’s not… she’s different. Different smart. But she’s nice. Very nice. And she likes us.”

“Good to know.” Daniel smiled.

Sam felt a little uneasy. An artificial intelligence in charge of a ship? Or so it seemed. And one that seemed to be a little off, if she understood Entrapta correctly?

“Quite a cosy ship,” the Colonel commented with fake casualness. “And no golden hieroglyphs plastered all over the place. I approve.”

“‘Golden hieroglyphs’?” Bow asked.

“The Goa’uld are fond of covering walls with boasts and praises to themselves,” the Colonel said.

“A not uncommon practise of absolute rulers,” Daniel added. “At least in Earth’s past. Although there are still a few countries where the leaders foster a cult of personality.”

“Don’t give the clones ideas,” Catra commented with a grin.

Adora grimaced. Right, she didn’t like followers.

They reached the bridge.

“Oh, very spacious,” the Colonel said. “Lots of room for expansion. And a big Captain’s chair. Roddenberry would approve.”

As would several other science fiction authors, Sam knew. Not that she would mention that.

“You wouldn’t want to travel in cramped space for months, would you?” Glimmer asked. Anyway, we’re just going into orbit so Adora can show you the plant that’s left of Horde Prime’s flagship.”

“Right!” Adora sat down in the Captain’s seat.

Sam looked around. There was a row of other seats that looked as if they were intended for passengers. They also seemed to be new - and done in a different style.

“Just take a seat!” Entrapta said. “Or keep standing - this won’t take long.”

Before Sam could reply, the lights on the bridge flared, and holographic displays lit up. Engine data, navigational data, three-dimensional display of their surroundings… Sam tried to track everything. Ancient script, too.

“Darla, lift off!” Adora said.

And the displays shifted - as did the view through the windows.

“Smooth ride,” the Colonel said as they shot up through the atmosphere, allowing Sam to catch a glimpse of the continent below them.

“Yes. It was a little bumpy before I fixed the gravitational generators,” Entrapta said.

Which reminded Sam that they were flying in a ship restored after a crash. She couldn’t help being wary of that. All the structural stress this would have caused, metal fatigue, warping… This wasn’t an airplane, she reminded herself, nor was it built by humans. She couldn’t judge it by those standards. She…

The Colonel whistled. Sam just stared.

There was a plant floating in orbit. A huge plant. In space. This was…

Was this a decoy? A station made to look like a plant? But why would anyone do that?

She shook her head. A plant in space.

“The bioengineering possibilities...” she whispered. Could they grow spaceships? At least the hulls? But how had they done this?

*****

In Orbit above Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“How did you do this? Did you grow it in space?” Carter asked.

Catra smirked. The woman looked… well, not unlike Entrapta when she found a new piece of First Ones tech.

“Well, kind of - if you consider transforming as growing,” Entrapta replied. “As we said: This was Horde Prime’s flagship. Until Adora transformed it.”

Carter turned her head to stare at Adora. “You transformed a spaceship into… this?”

“Yes.” Her lover was slightly annoyed, Catra could tell. Well, no one liked being thought a liar. Except for Double Trouble. “I used the magic of Etheria to transform the ship onto a plant.”

“Why?” Daniel asked.

“We were fighting him. With the ship, he could’ve bombarded the planet at leisure,” Catra explained.

“No, no - I mean, why turn it into a plant?” Daniel cocked his head and adjusted his glasses.

“Oh.” Adora blinked. “It was… instinct, as I said. I had all this power and had to use it. And plants don’t drop bombs or shoot cannons at you.”

In other words, she hadn’t had any idea what she was doing. But that wasn’t something you told the guests you were trying to impress. So Catra nodded in agreement.

“Magic is tied to life, sort of. Castaspella is the expert - the leading expert - on magic - but the basics are that magic needs life to grow. There’s possibly also a reciprocating effect, but that hasn’t been verified yet, though some data indicates it,” Entrapta explained. Or tried to explain. “So, from a conceptual point of view, plant growth is a natural effect of magic. Or the base of magic.”

“It’s tied to life?” Carter asked.

“Barren planets don’t have magic,” Entrapta told her. “Well, they lack the potential to have magic would be more precise, seeing as most planets don’t have magic at the moment.”

“But we’re working on that!” Adora told the others with a smile.

“Are you saying that magic was taken from the galaxy?” Carter asked.

“We don’t exactly know,” Adora said. “But we know the First Ones, who were not native to Etheria, used magic - but that none of the planets we discovered once Etheria was returned to this sector had magic.”

‘Returned to the sector’? Something else Sam had to ask about, later.

“Yes! It could be a local effect - I was theorising that the First Ones siphoned all available magic in the sector - or their Empire - to fight Horde Prime,” Entrapta said, nodding excitedly, “but if your planet doesn’t have any magic, either, and isn’t in the local sector according to your astronomical data, then this might have been a wide-spread effect.”

“How would you remove magic from the galaxy?” O’Neill asked with a grimace. “It’s a rather big place.”

Entrapta ignored his sarcasm and beamed at him. “That’s exactly what I asked myself! It didn’t make any sense - and the time involved…” She nodded. “But now that we know that there’s a Stargate network linking so many planets… We need more data!”

“You mean they used the Stargates to… syphon off magic from all the worlds?” Carter didn’t sound as if she believed that.

Hell, Catra didn’t really believe it. She was no expert on magic, but she knew - roughly - how big the galaxy was. And if this network was as big as their guests claimed, then even if all those planets had only had a trickle of magic each, it should’ve been more than the Heart of Etheria could gather. The First Ones should have defeated Horde Prime with such power. Unless it was really inefficient or something. Or, she thought, it was used to construct the Heart of Etheria.

Well, Catra was neither a sorceress nor a princess. She could let others sort this out. “So, now that you’ve seen the remains of

Horde Prime's flagship, are you convinced?" she asked.

"Convinced of what?" O'Neill asked. He was back in control, or so it seemed.

"That I told you the truth," Adora said.

"Well… it's a big plant, yes. And a space plant."

"But to transform metal and plastic into plant matter…" Carter trailed off. "The amount of computing power you'd need for that, on this scale… Unless it's a self-propagating process, spreading from a point of origin, like nanomachines replicating and transforming as they grow..."

"It was transforming magic," Entrapta said. "Totally different process, same effect. But what you just mentioned sounds interesting! How do you make such nanomachines?"

"Ah… that was only theorised. Although I have a few ideas about that…"

"Ideas that we're not going to experiment with, Carter," O'Neill said. "We don't want a grey goo scenario, do we?"

"Grey goo?" Entrapta tilted her head to the side.

"I wasn't aware that you were familiar with the concept, sir," Carter said.

"I read more than just the briefings," O'Neill replied.

"You read the briefings? Daniel blinked in apparent surprise.

O'Neill glared at him but didn't comment.

"What is grey goo?" Catra repeated Entrapta's question.

"Ah, sorry!" Carter smiled at them. "It's a hypothetical doomsday scenario in which nanomachines self-replicate by converting everything - plants, animals, people and even solid matter in

some scenarios - into more nanomachines. Effectively turning a whole planet into a mass of nanomachines."

Catra shivered. That sounded…

"That's horrible!" Adora exclaimed, echoing Catra's thoughts.

"And you have ideas about that?" Bow shook his head.

"Theories. No practical work has been done - we don't have the capability to create nanomachines on that scale," Carter said.

That was a relief. But it was another clue that their guests were far more dangerous than they appeared. They couldn't underestimate them. No matter how surprised they were by magic.

Nor could they underestimate the Goa'uld.

*****

This spaceship was far too spacious, in Jack O'Neill's opinion. The bridge had enough room for an army. An army of giants. Yet the doors were normal-sized - well, sized so the seven-foot amazon could walk through it. What kind of people built spaceships like this? Not even the Goa'uld wasted space like that.

At least it looked like their hosts had started to use the space for something, what with the shiny looking seats they had installed. Still… you didn't carry your passengers on your bridge. That was just asking for trouble in a fight.

"So, you don't have nanomachines? But you've been thinking about them?" Entrapta asked. Far too eagerly, for Jack's peace of mind. He had almost died to those hellish things, after all.

"We've encountered the technology before, and we're working on exploring it, and considering several scenarios, to counter such threats," Carter replied. Good. No need to make them think that

Stargate Command was planning to turn planets into grey goo. Or make every one die from old age in a few days.

"And to use it yourself," Catra added.

Well, that was a logical deduction - you tended to use the weapons you had, after all. Especially when fighting an enemy that had you outnumbered and out-teched like the Goa'uld. But in this case, they were wrong.

"We wouldn't destroy a planet!" Daniel protested.

"Not even to win a war?" Catra tilted her head. "Not even to save your planet and everyone else?"

Something was off here. Everyone else was watching intently, Jack realised. This wasn't just an idle question.

And Daniel was faltering. "Well…"

"We wouldn't kill the entire population of a planet to defeat the Goa'uld," Jack said. "Our laws forbid attacking civilians." Of course, there were exceptions. If the Goa'uld used their slaves as human shields… But uncontrolled nanomachines? No.

But the others seemed to have accepted his statement. Catra nodded, and Adora looked relieved. Bow smiled.

Then Carter added: "Besides, the risk of unlimited nano-warfare is too great. Like biological warfare."

"Biological warfare?" Glimmer asked. She glanced at the space plant floating in front of the ship, Jack noticed. Were they thinking of that? Battling plants?

"Weaponised germs," Carter explained. "Diseases engineered to infect enemy soldiers and disable or kill them. We don't use them, but we had to research them and develop countermeasures since our enemies used them."

That seemed to shock everyone. “Diseases?” Adora blurted out. “The Goa’uld use diseases as weapons?”

“They have no qualms about using such dishonourable weapons,” Teal’c stated with a slow nod.

“Monsters!” Glimmer whispered.

Even Catra looked grim as she nodded in apparent agreement. “We have to consider how to defend against that, then.”

“I can heal a disease,” Adora said.

“An entire planet’s worth?” Catra asked, turning to look at the woman.

“There are protocols to isolate and stop such an attack from spreading,” Carter said.

“And there’s the threat of retaliation,” Jack said. “We found that that worked well with chemical weapons.” Not even Hitler had used poison gas on the battlefield.

“Chemical weapons? Poison?” Catra asked.

“Yes.”

Their hosts were looking at the catwoman.

“Poison that kills people or plants?” Adora asked.

“People,” Jack replied. He wasn’t about to go into Agent Orange. Filthy stuff - if he had run into it…

“Ah.” That seemed to relieve Catra. Had she proposed such an attack herself? Or used poison as a defoliant? A question for another day.

Jack cleared his throat. “So, this was your enemy’s flagship. What’s it doing now?” He nodded at the space plant outside.

“Uh…” Adora bit her lower lip.

“We don’t actually know,” Entrapta said. “Perfuma checked it and said it’s a harmless plant and that it should survive in space, but that’s about it. We don’t know what it does, other than that it absorbs sunlight.”

That was… On Earth, there would be half an army of scientists in orbit, studying the thing. And they had sent one expert and then let it be? That made no sense. Unless… Unless all their experts were busy on the ground, dealing with the damage of the war. Or if they didn’t have enough experts to handle this. “Perfuma?”Jack asked.

“The Princess of Plumeria,” Entrapta replied. “She can control plants - make them grow and move.”

Ah. So, another magical princess. Jack would have to check with Daniel about this planet’s society. Did they have many scientists? Entrapta was one, of course, but she also was a princess.

“Is she your leading expert on botany? Daniel asked.

“Pretty much, yes,” Catra said.

“She’s helping Scorpia with the agriculture of her kingdom,” Entrapta said. “They have a lot of former Horde soldiers settling there, so they need a lot of produce. And Adora’s magic turned the place fertile, but her plants aren’t really suitable for eating.”

“Sorry,” Adora mumbled.

“It wasn’t your fault, dummy!” Catra told her. “Besides, without you, nothing would grow there. You know how the Fright Zone was.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded.

An interesting interaction. Catra seemed familiar with the Fright Zone as well. Of course she would be if her troops had operated

there. Still… Jack knew he was missing pieces of the puzzle. "So… this is your personal ship?" he asked.

"Well, it was Mara's, and she was She-Ra before Adora," Entrapta said. "But they let me tinker with it!"

"As long as you don't blow it up," Catra added.

"I won't!"

Jack was about to ask a few more questions about the ship's capabilities when a noise - an alert - sounded on the bridge.

"Oh! A frigate is moving toward us!" Entrapta said.

So, this was one of the frigates they had mentioned. The ship that appeared on the screen looked far different from 'Darla'. Bright colours - white mainly - and less angular curves. A completely different style, Jack noted.

This should be interesting.

*****

"Which frigate?" Adora asked. She didn't add 'Please, not the Third Fleet. Please, not the Third Fleet' under her breath, mainly because Catra would hear her, but she was thinking it.

"Three-One," Bow replied from where he was looking at the screens.

First of the Third. The flagship of the Third Fleet. Adora hung her head.

"Incoming call," Bow added, looking over his shoulder at Adora.

She sighed. "Yes."

He pushed a button, and a smiling clone appeared on the large screen in front of them. A clone with a silver diadem of a very familiar design. 'Priest'. "Your Divine Highness!" he beamed at her,

then bowed deeply. So deeply, Adora only saw his back when he proclaimed: "Your slightest wish is our holy command! How may your fleet serve you?"

"Wow. I thought you weren't really formal, but that… That takes the cake," O'Neill commented, followed by a hissed 'Jack!' from Daniel.

"Ah. We're just showing our guests the space plant," Adora explained. "No need for an escort. Or an orbital strike. Or an invasion," she added hastily.

"Guests?" Priest straightened and cocked his head as if he hadn't noticed their visitors before. He probably hadn't, actually, since he added. "And good day, Holy Consort and Companions of the Divine She-Ra!", with a deep nod towards Catra and the others.

Adora suppressed a shudder. Priest sounded far too much like Horde Prime when he spoke like that.

"Holy Consort?" O'Neill cocked his head towards them.

Before Adora could explain, Priest spoke up: "Catra, the Holy Consort of the Divine She-Ra, first to be saved by her love, before we all saw the light."

Adora heard the groan from Catra at that, but Priest either didn't or ignored it. Not that he'd change, anyway.

"Ah, nice." O'Neill nodded. "I'm Colonel Jack O'Neill, from Earth. This is my team - Captain Carter, Daniel Jackson and Teal'c."

Priest nodded. "Well met, and be welcome…" his smile faltered as he looked at Teal'c. "Jaffa?" he spat with a growl.

Uh-oh! Adora winced.

"I do not serve the false gods," Teal'c declared before Adora could say anything. "I fight the Goa'uld."

And Priest beamed at the guy. “Another soul saved by the Divine She-Ra! Praised be her name, blessed be her followers!”

“Did he just bless himself?” O’Neill added in a low voice.

Adora cleared her throat. “They were stranded on Etheria, and we’re looking into helping them return to their home.”

Priest frowned again. “They aren’t from Etheria? I wasn’t aware that any ship slipped through our perimeter. When did this happen? Did the heretics fail their most basic duties?”

“Wrong Hordak did nothing wrong!” Entrapta protested. “They arrived through a Stargate.”

“A Stargate?”

“A device from the First Ones which allows instant travel from one gate to another, across the stars,” Entrapta explained. “Kinda like a transporter, but it needs another gate to lock on, although it can cover much, much greater distances. There’s an entire network spanning the galaxy!”

“Oh.” Priest blinked. “And such a gate is on Etheria? And there are others? A network? Your Divine Highness, we must guard this gate! Please allow us to deploy the Holy Legion to safeguard Etheria!”

Yeah, right. Glimmer would kill Adora if she told Priest to deploy a few thousand clones and even more bots on Etheria. “I have secured the gate personally,” Adora told the clone. “Rest assured that should we require your help, you will be called at once.”

And the clone was beaming at her again. “Of course! Blessed is the planet under your protection and guidance, Your Divine Highness!” Another deep bow.

“So, ah… just resume your duties,” Adora added. “We just wanted to show the remains of Horde Prime’s flagship to our guests.”

“Of course! Everyone should visit the place where the scourge of the galaxy was purged at least once in their lives to bask in the sight of the silent witness of your divine glory!”

“Oh, boy,” O’Neill muttered.

“Ah… right.” Adora forced herself to smile. That wasn’t why they had taken their guests up here. She raised her arm and waved. “So… return to your duties, Priest.”

“At your command, and with your blessings, Your Divine Highness!”

The screen blinked out, and Adora sighed.

“I’ve known a number of Goa’uld who’d be very jealous of such devotion,” O’Neill said.

“Indeed.”

“It’s not as if Adora wanted this,” Glimmer said, scowling. “They latched onto her and won’t take no for an answer.”

“I tried telling them that I’m not a goddess or their goddess,” Adora explained. “They aren’t listening.”

“Well, you did kill Horde Prime and turned his flagship into a space plant,” Catra said with a shrug. She, of course, found the clones’ devotion funny. Most of the time. “And it’s better that they follow you rather than anyone else.”

Oh, yes. Blindly fanatical clones with a fleet, following someone selfish, cruel or greedy...

“Are they all like that?” O’Neill asked.

“Only the Third Fleet,” Bow said. “Second Fleet is led by Wrong Hordak. They don’t think She-Ra is a goddess but are still grateful for being freed from Horde Prime’s control.”

“And those who do consider them heretics?” Daniel asked.

“Yes,” Adora admitted. “But I forbid any attempts to, ah, convert them.”

“Is there a First Fleet?” Carter asked.

“There was,” Catra said. “But their ships were mostly destroyed with the flagship. Not many are left - a dozen or so.”

“Hordak has been talking to the remnants,” Entrapta added. “They are kinda lost, what with having lost so many in the war.”

Lost at her hands, Adora knew. And the clones hadn’t known any better. They had just followed their creator’s orders, as they had been raised to. Like Shadow Weaver had tried to raise her.

She clenched her teeth. She wouldn’t think about Shadow Weaver and what the woman had done to her and Catra. Not now.

*****

Adora was still tense, Samantha Carter noticed. The whole situation must be stressing her. Which, as cynical as it sounded, was a good thing - if she embraced such worship… Sam knew that this was what the Goa’uld wanted. Utterly loyal followers who worshipped them as gods. Who could resist such power?

“It’s still fascinating,” Daniel said. “I didn’t expect this to be so… direct. Although in hindsight, it makes sense. Converts are often the most fanatical of any religion’s followers.”

Sam winced - Daniel had let his scientific curiosity get the better of his tact, again.

“Sorry,” Adora said, looking dejected. “I’m working on this, but… you’ve seen how they are.”

“It’s a work in progress.” The Colonel nodded. “Don’t worry. Deprogramming a cult takes time.”

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded. “I know the trials it takes to make my people accept the truth.”

“Thanks.” Adora’s smile was weak but seemed honest.

“But at the least, the fanatics are fighting for you,” the Colonel went on. “Are there any other fleets left?” Fishing for more information, Sam realised. A little underhanded, but they needed to know more about this world.

“There should be,” Entrapta replied. “But we’re not quite sure how many. Horde Prime was conquering the sector, yet there were rebellions all over the place by the time Adora defeated him, so his Horde was split up.”

“So, there are more of those… clones… around? With fleets?” Daniel asked.

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “We are trying to track them down, but… We lost the way to contact them with Horde Prime’s flagship.”

“And reconstructing the deployment orders from the surviving data hasn’t worked out,” Entrapta explained. “Horde Prime controlled them personally, so all that knowledge died with him.”

“We’ve been sending out ships to explore the sector, but it’s going slow,” Bow added.

“And we don’t really want to send out the Third Fleet,” Queen Glimmer said.

“Imagine them meeting a fleet and considering them heretics!” Catra snorted. Sam didn’t think it was funny. Then again, the Colonel made similar jokes.

But… Religious fanatics on a crusade in space - and former soldiers of a megalomaniac dictator who razed planets for resisting him, at that? She could imagine the horrors such a conflict would unleash. Although… “You lack a complete overview

of Horde Prime's former empire?" Hadn't Horde Prime kept his data properly backed up?

"Yes. We think we have the gist of it," Entrapta told her, "but not the details. Though we're working on it. It just takes time."

"They recognised me," Teal'c pointed out.

"Yes." The Colonel nodded. "They must have met Jaffa before."

Sam nodded. That made sense. "And since they couldn't see your stomach or sense the larva inside you…"

"Junior!" the Colonel cut in.

Sam ignored him. "...they must have recognised the symbol on your head or the staff weapon," she finished.

"Or both," Daniel said. "Yes, they must have had contact with the Goa'uld." He smiled. "That means they might have navigational data about the Goa'uld holdings.

"Right!" Entrapta beamed at them. "Let's talk to Wrong Hordak!"

"Not Hordak?" Sam asked. Entrapta had mentioned that he was her partner, after all.

"Uh, no. He's been out of touch with Horde Prime for a few decades." Entrapta winced and shook her head, her hair staying still somehow. "And the First Fleet's remnants are still a little, uh, shaken up. Wrong Hordak, though, is leading the Second Fleet, which is mostly intact. They are bound to be our best source about the Goa'uld. Though if they know nothing, then odds are, it's just the Third Fleet who knew about Goa'uld. Which would, by itself, be useful data, of course!"

"Let's hope we don't have to talk to the Third Fleet," Adora muttered.

“Right,” The Colonel agreed. “My quota for bombastic religious sermons is already full. For this year.”

That sent a few of their hosts snickering. Not Adora, though, Sam noticed.

“Sorry,” Adora said. “I try to tell them to tone it down, but…” She shrugged.

Though, Sam couldn’t help thinking, given the fanaticism she had observed, it might be dangerous to tell those clones to stop following Adora at all. They might take offence and lash out. Or, possibly worse, they might listen.

“So, you have three distinct groups amongst the former Horde?” Daniel asked.

“Four if you count the former Horde on Etheria,” Bow corrected him. “Though they have split as well.”

“Most of them are staying in Scorpia’s kingdom. Some of them have turned into bandits and pirates,” Queen Glimmer explained. “At least the clones haven’t done that.”

“As far as we know,” Catra pointed out. “Some of them could be conquering planets out there.”

“So far, we haven’t heard anything about that,” Queen Glimmer replied with a frown.

Sam watched both. It felt like an argument they had had before. Two leaders, clashing over the best course of action? But Catra was, as far as they knew, not a princess. And all leaders so far seemed to be princesses. Or clones. Sam would have to ask Daniel about the possible ramifications of that.

“Well, isn’t that a wonderful thought,” the Colonel commented.

“It’s quite common for soldiers to turn into bandits or mercenaries after a war if the social structures that supported them before

broke down, which might be the case here," Daniel said. "We have numerous examples in Earth's history," he added.

"Oh?" Catra tilted her head.

"We've had many wars," Daniel told her, "and there are several civil wars currently being fought on Earth, or having been fought until a short time ago."

"*Several* civil wars?"

Their hosts seemed shocked again.

And the Colonel wasn't amused.

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The Moon of Enchantment

In Orbit above Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Those people had multiple civil wars? All currently going on on their planet? Catra couldn't help but stare at them. That was…

"That's like the Age of War," Glimmer said, shaking her head.

"The Age of War?" Adora asked, to the relief of Catra - so she wasn't the only one who didn't know what that was.

"A time of great upheaval in Etheria," Bow started lecturing, "when every kingdom was pitted against every other kingdom. This was about eight hundred years ago - the exact date is contested amongst historians. Some say it started when the precursor kingdom of Plumeria attacked Bright Moon's first settlement. Others claim the Age of War began when that conflict spread to involve the Kingdom of the Forest and the Serpent Empire."

Right, Bow was the son of two historians, Catra remembered. Or amateur historians - neither Bow nor Adora had been completely clear about that, and Glimmer had only chuckled at both when the topic had come up.

"I've never heard of those two kingdoms," Adora said. "And I've studied all kingdoms when we prepared for the Princess Prom."

Catra snorted. Adora hadn't changed at all - she still overprepared for everything.

"They didn't survive the Age of War," Bow said. "The Kingdom of the Forest occupied parts of the Whispering Woods. When they faced defeat at the hands of Bright Moon and their allies, they tried to use the Whispering Woods' monsters against them. But the monsters turned against them, and so the kingdom was abandoned and taken over by the woods. Parts of it were absorbed by Plumeria two centuries afterwards, following their

conflict with Salineas, but they never managed to recover the whole area."

"Yes, Mom told me about that time. Bright Moon was one of the most advanced kingdoms, and everyone wanted a piece of it - or wanted to destroy it," Glimmer explained. "But Mom had already bonded to the Runestone, so the enemy armies couldn't break through the shield."

Queen Angella had been around that time? Catra had known that the former Queen of Bright Moon had been around for a while, but to have lived for centuries?

"Ah… how long is a year on Etheria?" Daniel asked.

"Three hundred and sixty days, why?" Bow replied.

"How long is a year on Earth?" Entrapta asked, recorder out.

"Three hundred and sixty-five days," Daniel replied. "And a quarter day, more or less."

"How does that work?" Entrapta cocked her head. "Do you have quarter days or how?"

"Wait, wait - are you saying that your mother, the former queen, was alive *eight hundred years* ago?" O'Neill asked.

"Yes." Glimmer nodded, apparently confused about the question.

Catra wanted to sigh at her naivety. "She was an exception. No one else is that long-lived," she explained.

"You forgot Madame Razz!" Adora objected. "She was around when Mara arrived a thousand years ago."

Catra hadn't forgotten the witch - though she had *tried* to forget her. The old woman's ramblings made her skin crawl.

"Right. A thousand years old." O'Neill sounded sceptical.

“It’s not really unbelievable,” Daniel said. “We’re talking about an alien species.”

And someone who was trapped between dimensions because of Catra’s fuck-up. She cleared her throat. “And what about the Serpent Empire?”

“I know! They were located where the Crimson Waste is situated now,” Entrapta said.

“Yes,” Bow went on. “Back in the Age of War, the area was, well, not a waste. Still arid, but they could grow crops. But they were expansionist and pushed out against the neighbouring kingdoms. They had various alliances but tended to betray their allies whenever they felt they could gain an advantage. They did well in the Age of War, but the desertification of their lands doomed the kingdom. Some scholars claim that this was caused by their attempts to construct a runestone to control the earth. Others think that the Princess of Salineas used her runestone to drain most of the area’s water into the ocean.”

Catra blinked. “Mermista could do that?” she asked before she could control herself.

“Err… not to my knowledge,” Bow told her. “That’s why it’s not a popular theory. Its proponents claim that Mermista’s ancestor used dangerous rituals to enhance the power of the runestone.”

“Ah.” Not a safe topic, then.

“Anyway, the Age of War ended with the Treaty of Bright Moon, seven hundred and five years ago,” Bow said. “But during that time, there was not a year when no kingdom was at war.”

“And afterwards, peace reigned until the Horde arrived?” Daniel asked, cocking his head.

“Ah, no,” Bow replied. “But the wars were generally smaller and more limited. The treaty started the regular gatherings that would become the Princess Prom to settle conflicts diplomatically.”

"Generally, as long as the Elemental Princesses were in agreement, they could enforce their decision on anyone," Glimmer added. "So, most wars were either between smaller kingdoms or short-lived affairs between Elemental princesses, like the Orange War four hundred years ago. Few wanted to risk war after the horrors of the Age of War, so such conflicts were very rare."

"The Orange War?" Adora asked.

"A sailor from Salineas stole - allegedly stole according to Mermista - an orange from Plumeria. A prized orange the then-princess had cultivated herself. She demanded restitution, the Salinean princess offered the price of a normal orange, the Plumerians insulted them, and war broke out. A failed invasion at sea and a failed landing on the shores of Plumeria later, the war was over," Glimmer said.

So, the Plumerians weren't always such pushovers. Good to know.

"You went to war over some royal orange?" O'Neill sounded surprised.

"The USA and the United Kingdom had a war over a pig," Daniel said.

"Yes, yes," Catra cut in. No need to dwell on that. "But let's get back to the point: You have multiple civil wars going on in your world?"

Daniel grimaced. "Right. That's true."

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Jack O'Neill suppressed a grimace - he knew Daniel could be more subtle - and took a step forward. "Yes. We have several civil wars going on on our planet. However, the vast majority of our people is living in peace."

"How many wars are going on?" Adora asked.

"Ah…" O'Neill frowned. Angola, Sudan, Sri Lanka, Sierra Leone, Yugoslavia, Algeria… he was sure that he was forgetting a couple in Africa. Burundi, for one. But there were bound to be more. "I think about a dozen," he said.

"A dozen?" Adora gasped.

"How many kingdoms - countries do you have?" Bow asked.

"Almost two hundred," Jack replied. "We've got almost six billion people on Earth."

"Six billion people!"

"That's…"

"How do you feed so many?"

"Rations. Must be rations. They don't have magic to speed up growth."

Jack cleared his throat. "We've got very advanced agriculture." He glanced at Daniel, but, for one, his friend wasn't about to mention the environmental impact of industrialised agriculture. "We don't generally eat rations outside the military. And even in the military, rations are generally limited to the field."

"Hunger is a fact of life for many, though," Daniel piped up. "But there is enough food for everyone - or would be, if it were distributed evenly."

"No shit. Logistics must be hell with so many wars," Catra muttered.

"And why don't you intervene and stop those wars?" Glimmer asked.

Jack suppressed a sigh. "We do try that. But it tends to be bloody." He had operated in such countries - he knew the score.

“No one really likes foreign powers trying to control your country. If you invade, soon, many hate you more than their enemy. .”

“But if those are local wars, can’t you just smash their armies with superior forces?” Adora asked. “You have to outnumber them, right?”

Oh, damn. The kids thought those civil wars were fought like their wars apparently were fought. “Most civil wars aren’t fought with armies,” Jack told them. “They’re asymmetrical conflicts. Guerrilla wars. One side is generally outnumbered and hiding, striking at their enemies before fading away. They can fight for years with just small arms - they don’t need or have heavy weapons.”

Catra got it first. “Damn. And they hide amongst the civilians, right?” Jack nodded, and she winced.

“Oh.” Adora looked abashed.

“How can you tell the soldiers from the civilians in such a war?” Entrapta asked, looking puzzled.

“You can’t,” Catra told her.

“Oh.”

Jack nodded. “Yes. But as I said - the vast majority of Earth’s population lives in peace.”

“In ignorance,” Glimmer said. “You said they don’t even know they’re at war with the Goa’uld.”

Jack looked at her. They had gone over that already.

Adora cleared her throat. “So… now that you’ve seen the space plant, do you want to see anything else in orbit before we return to Bright Moon? There isn’t much to see, though. Just the First, Second and Third Fleet, basically.”

“And the moons!” Entrapta added. “Though they aren’t inhabited. But it’s neat to visit them - although you’d need spacesuits. I think I can adapt a few we have for you!”

To walk on a foreign moon? Jack was tempted. That had been his dream as a kid. How could anyone have seen Apollo 11 land on the moon and not wish to become an astronaut? But… “Don’t go to any trouble just for us,” he said.

“Oh, it wouldn’t be any trouble!” Entrapta beamed at them. “I’d like to explore the moons some more, too - there might be valuable materials on them that we lack on Etheria.”

So, they hadn’t yet explored the moons. That was interesting. They had spaceships, but old ones. And foreign ones. And no orbital infrastructure.

It didn’t look like Etheria had been to space for long. They might not even have the infrastructure to produce spaceships. Although the clones or whatever they were would have such facilities, they were likely not in this system. Or they had been on that huge space station and were now turning sunlight into plant mass.

“I think we have a lot of other things to do first, though,” Glimmer said.

“Like a potential war with parasitic snakes,” Catra added. “And a bunch of stranded soldiers we need to get home.”

Jack smiled, showing his teeth. “Right, exactly that!”

Catra frowned at him in return.

“So, no moon expedition?” Entrapta asked.

“Maybe later,” Bow told her. “Although… is your scanner ready?”

“Right! My scanner!” The princess perked up. “I just need to add some finishing touches, and we can scan for Naquadah on the entire planet from here!”

Jack smiled. That was good news! Once they found the DHD, they could dial home. And let the professional diplomats handle negotiations. The general would be mad enough about what they - mostly Daniel - had let slip already about Earth.

"Do you want to help me?" Entrapta asked.

Carter - of course - as well as Bow agreed, and all three left the bridge.

"So…" Daniel beamed at the others. "How many people live on Etheria?"

"Well… We've got about fifty million people," Glimmer said. "Kingdoms rarely take a census at the same time, so it's all just guesswork, and with the war, most numbers are out of date anyway."

That was… both more and less than Jack had expected. For a planet seeded by the Goa'uld, it was a lot. But for a native civilisation left in peace? That was very little.

"How long back go your records?" Daniel asked.

"Records? About a thousand years," Glimmer said. "The time of the First Ones. Anything before them isn't very well known."

"And you have almost six billion people?" Adora shook her head.

*****

Six billion people. That was… Adora couldn't even imagine so many people. Most planets they had visited - which, admittedly, hadn't been more than a handful in the months since Horde Prime's defeat - had populations more in the range of Etheria's. Or, rather, had had such populations before Horde Prime had conquered them.

But six billion people! That was like… over a hundred times Etheria's number! The population of a hundred planets, all living

on one planet? How did they fit everyone onto one world?

“You must have gigantic armies,” Catra said. Of course she would think of the military first.

“I wouldn’t say gigantic, but we do have a few million under arms,” O’Neill replied.

“Only a few million?” Catra sounded almost disappointed.

“They’re normal people, not an army with a planet,” Glimmer snapped.

Catra frowned at her. “They’re also fighting a war.”

“You heard them - it’s not that kind of war,” Glimmer retorted. “They can’t send an army through a Stargate.”

“But once we have a fleet there, they can move it with spaceships,” Catra said. “The Second or Third Fleet can transport a lot of people. They can’t supply as many, but the First Fleet’s fleet train should be intact, and they don’t need as many transport ships any more, so that should compensate.”

Daniel blinked. “Are you already planning to launch invasions from Earth?”

Adora frowned. Why did he sound surprised? Preparing for all eventualities was what a good commander did. And Catra was a good commander, even though she might not think so. She had almost beaten the Alliance, after all, when she had been leading the Horde.

“Of course!” Glimmer cut in. “If you have so many soldiers but no ships to transport them, and we can provide you with ships, then it only makes sense to use both our strengths.”

“Yeah,” O’Neill agreed. “Though preparing an actual invasion on a planetary scale will take a long time. You don’t just send an army off without sufficient training and exercises.”

“And the political implications…” Daniel shook his head. “Not to mention the problems with coordinating all the different militaries.”

Right. Adora nodded - she knew all about that. The scattered nature of the Alliance forces had almost driven her to despair a few times. She didn’t miss the Horde, of course, but she did miss their organisation, at times at least. And their discipline.

“Well, the heavy lifting will be done by the fleet. Orbital bombardment will deal with most defences. We can sort out the details when we reach Earth,” Catra said. “But your planet needs to be protected at all costs - it’ll be a prime target for the Goa’uld once it turns into a staging area.”

Adora nodded again. That meant a full fleet - Second or Third. Second was more, well, reasonable. They wouldn’t cause much trouble with the Tau’ri. The Third were fanatics. But if they left for Earth and the Third stayed guarding Etheria and the rest of the sector, would the clones behave without Adora being present? Would they even stay? She clenched her teeth. As much as she disliked it, they would have to take the Third with them to Earth.

“Yes, we are - the Goa’uld really don’t like us. And we have six billion civilians to protect,” O’Neill added. “Poor helpless civilians.”

Glimmer frowned at him. “Yes.”

O’Neill smiled, and it looked… Well, not quite like Catra’s smile when she thought she had pulled one over Adora and her friends, but she was sure it wasn’t an innocent smile. “We will protect your planet anyway,” she said. “Just as we will protect everyone else.”

Catra and Glimmer were frowning at her, but Adora ignored that. This was the right thing to do. As she had said before.

“Thank you!” Daniel beamed at her. “And we will do our best to help you.”

"Speaking for SG-1," O'Neill added. "We cannot speak for our country, much less the Earth."

Which was really inconvenient, Adora found. On the other hand, without princesses and magic, it made sense that the Tau'ri wouldn't send their leaders to the front. It probably made governing easier as well, especially with the frontlines being on another planet or in space.

"Yes, yes, we know that," Catra replied with a snort. "You're just good soldiers doing your duty." Why was she being so… sarcastic?

O'Neill smirked in return. "Well, we've been known to act independently in the field, as any good soldier would."

Ah. Adora sighed.

"But we really cannot speak for Earth," Daniel said.

"I am sure once the leaders of the Tau'ri are aware of the situation, they will do the right thing," Teal'c said. "Their history shows that they haven't shied away from going to war."

"Not forever, at least," O'Neill said.

"It's not a bad thing to hesitate to start a war," Daniel added.

"But you're already in a war," Catra objected. "I doubt that the Goa'uld will just stop if you don't want to go to war." She frowned. "Well, Plumeria did, but even they got the message after their kingdom almost fell."

Right. That hadn't been Adora's finest hour. Trying to figure out how to heal the forest… She felt embarrassed just remembering it. But that was in the past. They had a new war to fight now. A war on a scale that was even bigger than she had thought. And with much higher stakes.

She almost missed the time fighting the Horde on Etheria… No, Adora firmly thought as she glanced at Catra standing next to her,

reaching out to grab her hand, I don't miss that at all.

Catra looked surprised when Adora gently squeezed her hand but didn't pull away. Instead, she smiled at her with that happy expression Adora loved to see on her face.

*****

"Can you hand me the calibrated crystal, Bow?"

"Sure! Here it is."

"Thanks! What do the readings say?"

"Everything nominal."

"Good!"

Samantha Carter felt a little out of her depth, and she didn't like it. She was used to not understanding alien technology - at least at first - but she wasn't used to being the odd one out when working on said technology. Both Entrapta and Bow were familiar with this, but while Sam could easily identify parts of the scanner they were building - and help with assembling those - she was at a loss when it came to magic crystals. "How do you calibrate the crystals?"

"You tune them to the right frequency."

That sounded logical. And not very helpful. "And how do you do that?"

"I'll show you," Bow told her, stepping over to the table on the side of the workshop. "You have to align the crystals with each other and the master crystal, then run a pulse through them. Ah, a pulse from this crystal."

"Are you using magic?"

“Yes. Crystals generally use magic. You could use electricity, but it’s not nearly as efficient - the Horde did that for some of their gear,” Bow explained.

“And who creates the crystals?”

“Most are mined and then refined,” Bow replied. “Or tuned.” He shrugged. “It’s not exactly complicated, but it can take a while.”

“But that only gets you blanks. You have to program them with the right matrix to do anything, and that’s where the fun starts!” Entrapta cut in.

“Like… ROMs?” Samatha asked.

“ROMs?”

Sam explained the process.

“Oh! Yes, something like that! We generally use crystals for that. I have to try out your method!” Entrapta beamed at her, and Sam couldn’t help but smile back. The woman’s enthusiasm was contagious.

“I think the crystals are ready now,” Bow pointed out.

“They are? Good! Now let’s connect them to the power source and run some tests.”

That, too, made sense. Sam could easily track how those two components worked together. And the sensor itself was not much of a secret, either. She didn’t recognise a few components, but she had a rough idea about how to replace them with more familiar technology. Maybe a few bits from Goa’uld gear… She cocked her head. If you could substitute electricity for magic and she understood the program that the circuits used, she could duplicate this. Probably. It would certainly be fun to try - a planetary scale Naquadah detector would be very useful. Though… “How much less efficient is electricity compared to magic?”

“Oh, it depends. If you just want to shoot lasers or lightning, it’s decent. But if you want to use some of the more flexible parts of magic, like we are doing here, it’s generally a few orders of magnitudes less efficient. And you need a way to duplicate the principle of similarity.”

“The principle of similarity?” Sam asked.

“Yes. Like attracts like,” Entrapta said. “We will be using a sample of Naquadah as the primer to look for more. Magic is quite useful for such feats.”

That sounded as if the scanner wouldn’t just look for certain characteristics of Naquadah using data from prior scans, but that the presence of actual Naquadah affected and enhanced the process. That was… quite fascinating.

Sam smiled and looked at the scanner, then frowned. “And where is the sample?”

“Oh, we still need to get it. You’ve got it in your blood.”

Sam froze. “You want my blood?”

“Only a small sample - this is a scanner, after all,” Entrapta told her. “It’s powerful enough to only need traces of the element.”

“About this much,” Bow explained with a rueful smile, holding up a small transparent vial.

Well, she could spare that much blood. And the Colonel wasn’t here to object - or, worse, make fun of her. And she really wanted to see how this worked. So Sam nodded and rolled up her sleeve. “Alright.”

They extracted the blood using an old fashioned syringe. Not quite a bloodletting, but Janet had better instruments in the med bay back home.

“Done!” Entrapta smiled widely. “Now, let’s put it in the scanner and see what we get!”

“Yes!” Sam smiled back.

Entrapta put the trace - stored in a crystal vial, or so it seemed - into the scanner, then took a step back. “Ready!”

“You’re running it here?” Sam asked.

“Yes. Being inside Darla shouldn’t affect it. We might get more range if we placed it on the hull, but it already covers the planet.”

That was impressive. And a little worrying. “The scanner won’t affect us?”

“Oh, no - it’s perfectly harmless. Even for people with Naquadah in their blood.”

That was reassuring - and concerning. What if something else could affect her blood? Something to keep in mind.

“Booting up! Running diagnostics! Oh, it’s working beautifully! No tendency to explode at all!”

Sam hoped that the princess was joking. But Bow grimaced as well. Damn.

“Ok! Here we go!” Entrapta announced, her hair pushing several buttons at once.

And Sam heard a humming noise that quickly grew louder and louder. Just as she was about to plug her ears, the humming stopped.

And Entrpata frowned. “Oh. There’s no concentrated Naquadah on the planet other than the Stargate.”

Sam pressed her lips together. This wasn’t good. Not at all. They were now completely reliant on their hosts to get back to Earth.

And on technology that she didn't understand. Not yet.

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"We need to check the moons," Entrapta said. "There's no second Naquadah concentration on Etheria, which means there is no D.H.D. there, but they could've moved it to a moon for, ah, safety reasons."

"To keep people from using the Stargate?" Catra asked. As O'Neill and his group had shown, people could still arrive on the planet, but it would keep them from leaving. Not exactly a good way to stop an invasion.

"Or because they wanted to analyse the device without risking parts of Etheria," Entrapta replied, mimicking an explosion with her hands.

That was… Catra hissed at the idea.

"Naquadah isn't actually that dangerous," Carter cut in. "Unless you deliberately wanted to prepare a Naquadah-enhanced bomb, you won't get it to explode with sufficient force to be a threat to a planet."

That didn't sound as reassuring as the woman likely meant it to be, Catra knew.

"So… you just lose a building, not the kingdom?" Adora asked.

"Captain Carter hasn't lost any buildings due to Naquadah. So far," O'Neill said. "I can't speak for her labs, though."

"Sir!" The woman looked embarrassed, and O'Neill was laughing.

Catra snorted as well and ignored the looks from Glimmer and Bow. "Well, we can just quickly scan the moons for the thing."

"And tell Third Fleet to not come too close to avoid interfering with the scanning," Adora added.

“Actually, more ships shouldn’t affect the process at all,” Entrapta pointed out.

“But there’s no need to risk it, right?” Glimmer asked.

“Well… if there is interference, that would be valuable data, and we would need to test it anyway to see if we can deploy the scanner in a fleet - say, to detect other ships,” Entrapta explained.

That was a good point. Better find out now if that would work than in the middle of a battle. But if they had to listen to Priest again...

“Uh…” Daniel raised his hand.

“Yes?” Entrapta turned to him.

“There are no other concentrations of Naquadah on the planet?” Daniel asked.

“Not any which would be big enough to be the device you want,” she told him.

“But… didn’t the First Ones use this technology?” he asked.

“Apparently not.” Entrapta shrugged. “Most of them used magic as a base for their technology. It would’ve been nifty to find all their ruins, though.”

“Carter?”

“It seems that this culture didn’t rely on Naquadah, except for the Stargates, Sir,” Carter told O’Neill. “I’m sorry for not mentioning it sooner. They might have developed a new technology base.”

“A magical civilisation? Huh.” The man shook his head.

“Or they limited Naquadah to military uses,” Daniel said. “If there was a shortage of the metal, that would be a logical measure.”

And you didn’t risk civilians blowing you up by accident.

Carter nodded in agreement. “That is a possibility as well.”

“Or they moved it to a moon!” Entrapta blurted out. “We should explore them!”

“Right. Let’s go scan the moons,” Adora said. “If there are some First Ones bases on them, it’s better to find out now.”

“Before some doomsday device gets activated,” Catra added.

The way their guests nodded in agreement wasn’t very reassuring, in Catra’s opinion.

“Alright! Darla, fly us closer to... the closest moon!” Entrapta used her hair to carry their scanner and sat down in her favourite seat - the ‘science seat’, as she called it. “It’s time to discover what the moons are hiding from us!”

“She’s as eager as she was about space,” Glimmer muttered as Darla turned and started to fly towards the closest moon.

Catra shrugged in return. Entrapta was a little quirky, but there were not many other people Catra would trust with her life. And most were in this ship.

They quickly reached orbit around the moon, and Entrapta, Bow and Carter got busy with the scanner. Catra clenched her teeth as the infernal humming noise started up again. “First improvement will be to get rid of the noise,” she muttered. She wasn’t going to suffer every time they scanned something.

Adora didn’t say anything. Instead, she wrapped her arms around Catra and pulled close to place a quick kiss on the top of Catra’s head.

“Dummy,” Catra whispered. That didn’t help with the noise at all. But it helped with her mood. She ran her hands over Adora’s back. She could still feel, or thought so, where she had scratched her once. She tensed a little at the memory, but Adora held her firm - she knew Catra, after all.

Daniel cleared his throat next to them. “So, uh…”

Before Catra had to snap at the man, the scanner’s noise ended, and Entrapta spoke up: “There’s a large amount of Naquadah on the moon!”

“Carter?” O’Neill asked as Catra pulled away from Adora.

“Several concentrations, Sir. A few are large enough to possibly be a D.H.D. All in close proximity to each other.”

O’Neill smiled at that. “Great. Let’s go take a look.”

Catra bit her lower lip - this was a logical suggestion, not an attempt to order them around. At least it should be.

“Yes!” Entrapta cheered. “Let’s suit up.! Oh, I didn’t make you customised spacesuits yet! You’ll have to make do with standardised ones, sorry!”

“That’s OK,” O’Neill said. “We’re not picky.”

“Alright! Follow me, then!”! Entrapta led them to the locker room. Catra trailed behind them - she wasn’t needed on the bridge to land Darla, and someone had to keep an eye on Entrapta with those people.

Catra knew better than most how trusting her friend was.

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The First Moon of Enchantment, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“So, you come here often?” Jack O’Neill asked as they entered what looked like a locker room. A space locker room. “To the moon, I mean,” he added after a moment and a glare from Carter and Daniel.

“Oh, not really,” Entrapta replied. “There was so much to do, we haven’t had time to explore any of the moons. We just checked if there were clones stranded here or crashed ships. Or any ruins - but we didn’t do any deep scans or exploration. Which is why we must have missed this base; it’s underground.”

They hadn’t even explored the moons? Another clue that these people hadn’t had spaceships for long. And now they had entire fleets at their beck and call. Fleets manned by the brainwashed former soldiers of a genocidal conqueror. Great.

“And, of course, there’s the fact that, from a certain point of view, the moons belong to Glimmer,” Entrapta went on.

“They belong to her?” Daniel asked.

“Well, she’s the Queen of Bright Moon - and the Moonstone, her runestone, is connected to the moons,” Entrapta explained. “If they are in alignment, certain magic processes are strengthened or rendered more efficient.”

Jack clenched his teeth and suppressed the urge to sigh. Magic influenced by moons? Astrologians would have a field day back on Earth if they heard this. And some idiot congressman would likely want horoscopes to be used by the government.

“How does that work?” Carter asked. “Is it tied to radiation?”

“Kinda,” Entrapta replied. “They influence the magic field, of sorts.”

“Yes. Attacking Bright Moon when all three Moons of Enchantment were in the sky would’ve been suicide for the Horde,” Catra added.

“In myth, our moon was often said to have magical properties as well, such as influencing werewolves,” Daniel pointed out. “And many people believe that it influences humans - Tau’Ri.”

Superstitious folks did. The only thing the moon influenced was visibility at night and the tides. But that was without magic. If their hosts 'brought back' magic to Earth, would that change? Would they have trouble with actual werewolves?

"So… Here are our spare suits!" Entrapta pushed a button, and a panel slid back, revealing a rack of suits in various sizes. None of them looked as bulky as the suits Jack had seen at NASA. "They're not customised, as I told you before, but I can easily adapt them to your body type. Though yours might still be a little large," she added with a smile to Teal'c. "You're too big for a standard size and too small for a Scorpia size."

Teal'c nodded back. "I shall manage."

"Good!" Entrapta pulled the suits out and handed them over. "Now… just put them on as you would put on normal clothes. They'll seal automatically!"

That sounded very advanced. Jack wasn't an astronaut, but he knew that suiting up was a complicated process. But the suit he was holding did look pretty simple.

Carter looked impressed, too, as she studied her suit. "Do they use magic?"

"What? No. I didn't want them to have to rely on magic."

"You made them?" Carter asked.

"Yes! I used the pattern stored in Darla but adapted it to my own technology!" Entrapta beamed at them. "Do you like them?"

"They're very advanced," Carter told her. "I wish we had such suits at NASA."

"I can get you the pattern," Entrapta said. "It's really easy to construct."

Jack had his doubts, but he was sure the scientists at Stargate Command could construct such suits. Good work, Carter, he silently praised her.

The ship suddenly shook a little - they must have landed.

“Oh, you’ve missed the landing! I’m sorry - I got carried away a little,” Entrapta said.

“No worry,” Jack told her with a smile. “Once you’ve seen one landing, you’ve seen them all,” he lied.

“Well, they’re actually very different - but now, let’s get you suited up!”

Suiting up was actually as easy as the princess had claimed.

“We do need such suits,” Carter exclaimed. “If they can handle the environment on the moon’s surface...”

“Why wouldn’t they?” Entrapta replied. “That’s what they are made for - that and space!”

“They work,” Catra told them - her suit had a tail and cat ears on the helmet, Jack noted. They took their customisation seriously here. “We’ve tested them on various planets.”

That was reassuring. Jack wasn’t an expert, but he knew that constructing suits that could handle Earth’s moon had been a challenge. He closed up his own suit and moved around a little. The suit barely hindered his movements.

“Are you ready? Oh!” Glimmer entered, followed by the others. Not Adora, though, Jack noted. Was she staying back?

“I got carried away with explaining things,” Entratpa said. “Sorry!”

“No worry,” Bow told her. “We’ve got time.”

They grabbed their own suits - which were quite distinctly customised, down to different boots and patterns. Entrapta's suit had openings for her hair in her helmet - god only knew how that was sealed. Probably magic. Even though she'd said that she didn't use magic in the suits, the hair was supposedly magical. And Bow's suit had a… not a boob window, an abs window? Jack stared.

"Excuse me… Is there a reason for this?" Daniel asked. "Is showing your stomach of cultural significance?"

"What?" Bow blinked and put his helmet down again. "No. I just like it."

Catra snorted. "You should have seen his suit for the Princess Prom."

"And Catra's!" Entrapta added. Catra smirked in return. Was that related to being Adora's consort, as the clone leader had called her?

A question for another time - now they were about to explore a moon base. On a magical moon. Jack wasn't looking forward to writing a report about this.

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Adora had second thoughts about keeping her transformation a secret from their guests. Sure, not revealing to them right away that She-Ra wasn't her normal form was just being cautious. Until they knew if they could trust the Tau'ri, it was better not to let them know that they could attack Adora instead of She-Ra if they planned an ambush. But their guests didn't seem to be evil people. They hadn't shown any sign of planning to betray or attack them. O'Neill was snarky and grumpy, but in a kind of nice way. And he reminded her of Catra, in some way. Carter was fascinated by technology like Entrapta. And Daniel… Well, he gave the impression of an older Bow. Earnest, well-meaning and a little naive. She couldn't imagine him planning to betray her. Nor Teal'c,

though she couldn't say much about the tall Jaffa - he didn't say much, after all.

And, she added in her mind as she approached the airlock at the back of Darla, if keeping her secret was still necessary, as Glimmer had argued, then what about the fact that She-Ra could survive in the emptiness of space without a suit? Hiding your capabilities from potential enemies was smart, wasn't it? Unless you wanted to scare them into leaving you alone, but judging by their guests' reactions, not a lot scared them if they were ready to fight the Goa'uld.

She sighed, and Melog turned their head towards her, growling a question.

"Just thinking," she told them. She wasn't as good as Catra at understanding their friend, but she could guess some meanings.

"How do you seal the hair?"

That was Carter's voice.

"The helmet has adjustable seals," Entrapta replied.

"But how do they work? The pressure difference would be so significant..."

"It's a sort of semi-permeable force shield," Entrapta replied. "Only keyed to hair."

"Keyed to hair?"

"Yes? It's for my hair, after all."

They turned the corner and found the others already inside the airlock.

"You're not coming with us?" O'Neill asked.

"Yes, I am," Adora told him, stepping inside the lock as well.

“But where’s your… Let me guess, magic?” O’Neill shook his head with a snort.

“Magic,” Catra told him as she moved to Adora’s side. “Same for Melog.”

“Well, Melog being a half-energy life form means they can survive in the vacuum of space even without magic,” Entrapta explained as the door closed. Adora’s using magic to form a sort of magic space suit around her body.

As the air started to be sucked out of the lock, Adora took a deep breath - she knew she didn’t have to, but she couldn’t help it. Then she started to glow as her magic reacted.

“That’s going to be hard for a stealth mission,” O’Neill commented.

“She-Ra and stealth don’t mix well,” Catra said with a snort.

Adora pouted at her lover. She could be sneaky! She had proven that in the war. A few times, at least.

But before she could remind Catra of that - and of the fact that they had foiled a lot of her plans - the outer door opened, and they were facing the moon’s surface.

“Whee!” Entrapta was the first out of the door, jumping off the ramp as it extended and throwing up a small cloud of dust as she landed on both feet.

“Don’t get your hair all dusty!” Glimmer told her. “I’m not going to clean out the shower again!”

“You clean the shower?” Daniel asked.

“Not this time!” Glimmer replied. “Not when it’s all her fault.”

“Well, that’s going to shock the Queen of England,” O’Neill commented. “Royalty, cleaning up after herself…”

“Actually, Queen Elizabeth served in the British Army - the Women’s Auxiliary Territory Service - as a mechanic during World War II,” Daniel said. “She did menial tasks as far as we know.”

“Don’t destroy my hard-earned American preconceptions, Daniel,” O’Neill replied.

“Jack! Those would be prejudices!”

“Really?”

“Yes, as I pointed out…” Daniel trailed off to glare at his friend, and Adora heard O’Neill laugh as they walked down the ramp. She smiled as well - that sounded familiar to them.

“So, Queen Elizabeth is one of your princesses?” Glimmer asked.

“And she’s a mechanic?” Entrapta added, looking up from her recorder.

“She’s the Queen of England, a nation allied with ours,” Daniel replied. “But I do not think she has worked as a mechanic since she took the throne. And since she was crowned as queen, she isn’t a princess any more - at least not by our definition.”

That sounded weird to Adora. Glimmer was a queen as well, but still a princess.

“Well, your definition is weird,” Catra echoed Adora’s thoughts. “Though without magic, your princesses probably don’t have any powers.”

“Exactly,” Daniel replied. “It’s a title, nothing more.”

Adora looked around while Daniel explained about nobility on Earth. She couldn’t see any threat around them, but it never hurt to be cautious.

Catra snorted next to her. “Nothing on the surface. The fun starts once we enter the base.”

Right. Entering a First Ones base was always dangerous; Adora's ancestors hadn't been very careful with their weapons and other tools. They probably hadn't cared about a world they were sacrificing anyway, she thought.

She shook her head. This wasn't the time to dwell on that. Unless this base was related to the Heart of Etheria. The Moons of Enchantment did influence magic, after all.

"OK! The base is this way! Darla's seismic sensors indicate that there's a hollow space close to the surface right in this crater!" Entrapta announced.

"Let's go!" O'Neill said. "Before something goes wrong with the magic and you try to breathe vacuum."

"Sir!"

"Jack!"

"It's perfectly safe," Entrapta said.

Adora nodded. She-Ra had faced worse than the vacuum of space. Much worse.

"Yes, yes. Just let's go!"

"OK!" And Entrapta was off.

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The Moon Base

The First Moon of Enchantment, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"The entrance should be here. Somewhere here, at least," Entrapta said as she turned in place, pointing her multipurpose tool around. Something else that Samantha Carter would love to get her hands on to copy it. The device served as a computer and communication device with integrated holographic projection capability, but Sam was primarily interested in its capacity as a scanner. The tool was smaller than a walkie-talkie yet must be covering multiple frequencies. And - presumably - without magic.

So Sam was pretty confident she could duplicate it, given enough resources and time to study it. Of course, standing on the surface of one of the planet's bigger moons, she couldn't exactly spare the time for that. But maybe later…

"But my scanner isn't showing any entrance," Entrapta went on.

"Probably buried under all the dust," Catra remarked. "It's been a thousand years since the base was last used."

"That shouldn't have been long enough to actually bury any entrance. Not without wind to move the dust. Perhaps a meteor struck nearby, or tectonic activity…" Entrapta speculated.

"Or this is a dead-end, and the entrance is somewhere else," Glimmer said.

"Can you map out the base?" Bow asked.

"It's more difficult than I anticipated. The material used to construct the base is blocking most of my scans, and the results of those that aren't completely blocked are… not delivering as much data as they should."

“That would suit a base using the technology left by the Ancients,” Sam pointed out. It was petty, but she was almost glad that the others were not able to easily scan the base. The Ancients had been incredibly advanced, much more than any other race that Stargate Command had encountered so far. If the people of Etheria - Etherians? She had to ask Daniel if they used that name for themselves - were able to match the technology of the species that had built the Stargates, then that would likely make them the most advanced species known to either Earth or the Goa’uld.

Entrapta pouted, and her hair waved around for a moment. “But I didn’t have such troubles with First Ones technology so far.”

“If we don’t see an obvious entrance, we can dig a tunnel and just break through a wall,” Adora suggested.

“You mean, *you* can dig a tunnel,” Catra added.

“I already buried the Stargate!”

“Perfect! That means you’ve got experience!”

The Colonel chuckled at that, and Sam had to hide a smile - the exchange could’ve come straight from the Airforce Academy; it was the kind of comment the instructors were fond of. Another sign that their hosts had had formal training as soldiers. Though Daniel would likely caution against drawing parallels to Earth based on such flimsy evidence. In any case, they were here to explore a base, not to study cultural differences. She cleared her throat. “Can you scan for the most likely area that might have been buried following a meteor strike or tectonic activity? Without an atmosphere, any traces such an event has left should be still easily detectable.”

“Oh, good idea!” Entrapta raised her tool and started looking at it - or through it. “I was focusing on artificial structures, but… There! The crater there has some fresh - relatively fresh - traces of a landslide. Or dust slide, I’d say.” Her hair formed a cartoonish-looking hand and pointed to a ridge a few miles away.

“Well, then let’s see if we can find an entrance buried there,” the Colonel said. “You have your magical shovel ready to be conjured, right?”

“Yes,” Adora replied.

“Handy.”

It was. If Earth had that technology - or magic - then that would allow them to carry many more tools of all kinds with them. Or much larger tents.

They started walking. Once more, Sam felt a little envious - the spacesuits were far more comfortable and much lighter than those she had worn when she had been working for NASA. It was still noticeably heavier than her uniform, but the lower gravity more than made up for it, and she could move almost as well as without it. If her fellow astronauts could see her now, walking on an alien moon… Well, Entrapta had said she’d give them the pattern.

Of course, Adora didn’t have to wear a spacesuit at all, but she seemed to be a special case even for their hosts.

“So, why don’t you have a spacesuit?” Daniel asked. “Would it hinder your magic, or do you just like wearing your usual clothes?”

“Ah… You could say that,” Adora replied. “Like, ah, Bow, I prefer this.”

Sam exchanged a glance with the Colonel. That was a bad lie, in her impression. Of course, it was so bad, it could be an attempt to deceive them - but Adora hadn’t struck her as that devious or adept at lying.

Unlike, say, Catra.

“Ah.” Daniel nodded. “I see. So…”

“Oh, there it is!” Entrapta exclaimed, interrupting Daniel’s next question. “The entrance is buried here, about…” She cocked her head to the side as she moved her tool sideways. “...five yards down!”

“Great. Get digging, Adora!” Catra said, sitting down on a rock nearby.

Adora huffed but did produce her magic shovel. Her first load of moon dust did manage to barely miss Catra.

“Hey!”

“Sorry!”

“No, you’re not!”

Well, they were in good spirits, Sam thought. And with Adora digging, they would reach the base entrance in no time.

*****

Catra felt a little bad at having Adora do all the digging. Just a little, though - Adora was the strongest of their group. By far. Even if Catra helped, it wouldn’t do much compared to She-Ra using that oversized magic shovel of hers. Cartloads of dust and moon-ground - she’d have to ask Entrapta what it was called - pretty much flew out of the growing hole in no time. And it wasn’t as if anyone else had volunteered to help, anyway.

She studied the others - SG-1 - as Adora unearthed what would hopefully be the entrance to the First Ones base. Carter was huddled with Entrapta over the princess’s scanner. Teal’c and O’Neill were standing guard - O’Neill was trying to fake being bored, juggling a single moon rock, but Catra caught his eyes scanning their surroundings. And Daniel… was talking to Bow about Etheria’s history. Catra cocked her head and listened to their talk.

"...so, you have a detailed documented history of the last thousand years, but barely anything before that?"

"Yes," Bow said. "There just aren't many records or artefacts left from the time before the First Ones."

"That is weird." Daniel made a humming noise. "Few civilisations went from no records to detailed histories. It's generally a much more gradual process."

"Well, some scholars think that the First Ones introduced writing to Etheria. But my Dads disagree - that would have meant that all of Etheria would be using a script derived from their script. And that's not the case. In fact, few can read First Ones script or understand their language," Bow explained. "So, we think the proto-civilisations before their arrival had developed their own script already."

"But why wouldn't there be any records left, then?" Daniel asked. "Did the First Ones destroy them?"

That was an interesting question. Catra certainly wouldn't have put it past the First Ones to wipe out another civilisation - they had planned to sacrifice Etheria to defeat Horde Prime, after all. But why would they wipe out writing? That didn't gain them anything. It would be a waste of effort. Unless they wanted to hide something…

"They might have attempted to colonise the planet," Bow said. "And they might have wanted to, ah, spread their own culture over Etheria. Their influence is certainly visible in almost every kingdom, although after a thousand years, the divergences have become so pronounced, in many cases, it's hard to spot whether something is based on the First Ones or was originally developed by natives."

"Well, such policies certainly have historical precedents on Earth," Daniel admitted. "But to be able to shape an entire planet to that level…"

“They were far more advanced, both with regards to technology and magic, than the native cultures,” Bow said. “And they probably had significant numbers as well.”

“So… what happened to them? Why did they vanish?” Daniel asked. “Do the records cover that?”

“No. We only know that most of them ‘left’. But after the revelations of the last war, the consensus amongst scholars is that the First Ones were called back to their home planet to fight Horde Prime - or evacuated in anticipation of the destruction of Etheria.” Bow shrugged. “The remainders were probably absorbed by the emerging kingdoms.”

Catra nodded. That made sense. Though she didn’t think it mattered much. It had been a thousand years ago, after all. A metallic noise interrupted her thoughts.

“I’m through!” Adora yelled.

“Yay!” Entrapta was at the edge of the hole in no time. “Is it an entrance?”

“Wait a moment!” more dust flew out of the hole. “There’s a button labelled ‘open’.”

“It is an entrance!” Entrapta jumped down the hole, and Catra heard Adora make a surprised sound. “Hey!”

She peered over the edge. Yes, Adora had caught Entrapta. “We should install a ladder before we all get stuck down there,” she said.

“I’ll get one,” Glimmer said - and disappeared in a shower of sparkles. So, her magic worked this close to Etheria. Good to know.

“Now that’s handy,” O’Neill commented. “If she ever gets tired of being Queen, she has a great future as a delivery service.”

Catra snorted at the joke - Glimmer as a courier? - and even Bow smiled.

Then Glimmer returned with a rope ladder, and a minute later, Bow had set it up.

“Don’t come down yet!” Adora said. “I’m opening the door first! Entrapta, head back up. Just in case we have a monster hiding here.”

“It’s quite unlikely that a monster would have survived so long,” Entrapta replied. “Unless there’s a closed biohabitat here, which I think should have shown up on my scans. Although automated defence bots could be active. Or perhaps cryostasis pods, though they would likely need some time to thaw any specimen stored inside.”

“Come up, then,” Catra told her.

Entrapta quickly pulled herself up with her hair. “Clear!”

“Alright. Opening it now…” Adora announced. Catra heard her mumble ‘If this doesn’t work, it’ll be embarrassing,” under her breath as she reached out to touch the button.

For a moment, nothing happened. Then the door slid open, revealing a dark corridor leading downwards.

Catra jumped down the hole, landing in a crouch next to Adora. “Good work.”

“Careful!” Adora said as the rest climbed down. “We don’t know what’s in here.”

“That’s why we’re here!” Entrapta announced. “To explore!”

“Yes, well… let me go first,” Adora said. She entered before anyone could object.

And nothing happened - other than the hallway getting lit up by glowing crystals.

Catra followed her love. It was a short hallway - no, it was a large airlock.

“Let’s all go in so we can open the door without venting the air from the base!” Entrapta said. “That would be bad.”

Catra suppressed a sarcastic comment. To her slight surprise, so did O’Neill.

As soon as everyone was inside, the door behind them closed, and air started to fill the room with a hissing sound.

Then the other door opened, revealing a figure standing in the entrance. Catra gasped, then saw that it wasn’t a figure - it was a hologram. Like Light Hope.

“Greetings, visitors,” the projection said in that creepy voice of theirs. “Please identify yourself.”

“I am Adora - She-Ra,” Adora spoke up.

“Catra,” Catra snapped.

“Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon.”

“Bow.”

“Entrapta! Hi!”

“Colonel O’Neill.”

“Captain Carter.”

“Daniel Jackson.”

“Teal’c.”

“Greetings, Adora, Colonel O’Neill. Research Station Alpha is at your disposal. Please keep your test subjects from entering restricted areas.”

Catra blinked. Test subjects? And why was the bot talking to Adora and *O’Neill*?

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Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

What? Jack O’Neill stared at the computer hologram or whatever it was. Why was it singling out him and Adora? Hell, why was it treating him as if he were a seven-foot-tall amazon with magic powers?

“Test subjects?” Adora asked.

“The other life forms present have been identified as test subjects.”

“I’m not a test subject!” Catra spat.

“Sir,” Carter whispered next to him. “Why is it treating you as a... First One?”

“I don’t know, Carter!” he hissed back. He was a human, not some… alien. He couldn’t glow and step into vacuum as if it was a spring day in Colorado.

“What is the purpose of this station?” Daniel asked, taking a step forward. “What is it that you research here?”

“That information is restricted,” the computer - as far as Jack knew - replied.

“What do you research here?” Adora asked. “And who are you?”

“Research Station Alpha is the main research station for the experiments in genetic engineering conducted on Etheria. I am the primary computer system of the station, designation: Alpha.”

“She sounds like Light Hope,” Catra muttered. “Creepy.”

“It must be a common pattern for First Ones computer interfaces,” Entrapta said.

“They conducted genetic engineering experiments on Etheria?” Bow asked.

“What are those? And where did they do it?” Glimmer shook her head.

“Genetic engineering is the direct manipulation of an organism’s genes,” Entrapta explained. “Say, when you cross two plants so you can get an edible flower. Plumeria’s famous plum roses are said to be the result of early genetic engineering by their princesses.”

“Ah.”

“They talked about us being test subjects,” Catra said. “They weren’t experimenting with plants - they were experimenting with us!”

“They probably were experimenting with plants as well,” Etrapta pointed out. “Although, yes, I think you are… Oh.” She blinked with her mouth open.

“Yeah,” Catra said. “It looks like they used Etheria for more than just magic superweapon construction.”

Magic superweapons? Jack really didn’t like the sound of that. Though he didn’t like aliens experimenting with humans even less. In truth, he loathed it.

“Sir! If the Ancients - or the First Ones - experimented with human genetics, then that would explain the hybrid life forms we

saw in Bright Moon," Carter said. "If they were advanced enough to combine human and animal genes, that would entirely be possible!"

Jack suppressed a wince. Carter was a genius, but sometimes, she forgot about the social niceties.

"You think the First Ones… made us?" Glimmer glanced at Catra, then at SG-1. And she didn't sound amused.

"It's a hypothesis," Daniel replied with his diplomatic expression. "We don't know if it's true."

"But it fits what we know," Entrapta said, cocking her head. "And we can ask the system here. Well, Adora and Colonel O'Neill can ask her!"

Everyone was looking at Jack and Adora, he realised. Expecting them to ask? Or to spare them the knowledge? Well, Entrapta was beaming at them, so she would want to know.

And Jack wanted to know why he was treated as an alien. But how to ask without possibly telling the computer that it made a mistake? If it was a mistake in the first place…

"Alpha, show us an overview of the experiments performed on Etheria by people on this station," Adora said.

"It would be best to show that information in the main control room," the computer replied.

"Show us the way. Also, everyone here is authorised to enter the control room."

"Acknowledged."

Glowing arrows appeared on the ground and in the ceiling, showing them the way. Not that there were many junctions, anyway - after two minutes, they entered a big, round room

where half the walls were covered with screens and the centre taken up by a huge hologram.

"Genetic engineering research started soon after the discovery of Etheria since the planet's uncommonly high magic level facilitated research with advanced organisms, greatly reducing the rate of unviable results. Splicing various organisms with lesser First Ones stock resulted in various hybrid lines, many of which proved to be stable enough to reproduce without further manipulation necessary," the computer droned on while the scenes and the main hologram showed various humanoid species. Jack saw a Minotaur, lizard people, bug people - and cat people, amongst others.

"They made us. They made our people," Glimmer mumbled. Bow put a hand on her shoulder.

Jack clenched his teeth. This must be a shock for them. They would have origin myths, and to find out they were the result of experiments…

"Fascinating!" Entrapta beamed. "This answers so many questions! No wonder we can interbreed if we were engineered to be compatible and from a common ancestor!"

Apparently, not everyone was shocked.

"Entrapta!" Glimmer snapped.

"What? Did you never wonder why different species can have fertile offspring?"

"I thought that was done by magic," Bow said.

"Well, yes, usually, but it should be much harder than it is," Entrapta replied. "This explains so much!"

It probably did. But there were a few questions left. Crucial questions. Jack cleared his throat. "Alpha. What is my genetic status?" There, safe wording.

“Scans show your genes are free from mutations. There should be no problems with reproduction, should you so desire.”

“I meant my ancestry,” Jack clarified, clenching his teeth.

“We lack the data to identify your exact ancestry, but you are a descendant from a First Ones colonial family.”

What? That couldn’t be true. He was a human. Not an alien. He was born on Earth. Not on an alien colony.

Jack shook his head, Then he noticed that everyone was looking at him, even Adora.

“You’re a First One? Like me?” Adora asked.

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Adora… didn’t know what to feel. She had finally found someone of her, not quite family, but people. She wasn’t the only one left after Horde Prime had destroyed the First Ones. And yet...

“I’m not a First One, Ancient, or whatever!” O’Neill retorted with a glare. “I get checked out by our Napoleonic doctor and her big needles every week - I’m human.”

“Jack…” Daniel trailed off when O’Neill glared at him.

“Sir!” Carter stood straight. “Nothing indicates that the First Ones weren’t human.” She nodded at Adora.

“Do you see me walking around in space without a spacesuit, Carter?”

“That’s my magic,” Adora blurted out. “That’s not normal for me, either.” She couldn’t walk in space without being She-Ra, after all. And she had a spacesuit for when she was Adora.

“I can’t do magic, either,” O’Neill snapped.

“You have an aptitude for magic, Colonel O’Neill,” Alpha spoke up. “Like every First One. Although the power displayed by Adora indicates the first successful bonding with a Runestone for a First One. Did our experiments with the local test subjects finally bear fruit?”

“What?” What did Alpha mean? Adora looked around. The others seemed as confused as she was.

“Mom…” Glimmer mumbled. “What do you know about Mom?”

“Queen Angella?” Adora turned back to Alpha.

“No person or test subject of that name is in my data banks.”

“She wasn’t a test subject! She was the Queen of Bright Moon for centuries!” Glimmer yelled.

“Bonded to the Moonstone,” Entrapta added. “If that helps.”

“An extended lifetime?” Alpha tilted her head. “There were a few experiments to prolong the life of the test subjects. Although none of them was merged with those who were to bond with a Runestone.”

A number of people appeared as holograms. Adora stared. A mermaid, a huge figure that looked like Scorpia, just with more armour, a lizardwoman, and…

“Mom!”

Yes, there was Angella. “Who’s she?” Adora asked, pointing at the figure.

“Test Subject A-Gamma. Most successful bond to a Runestone to date. Hybrid with DNA material from an avian species from another magic-heavy planet.”

“Mom!” Glimmer shook her head. “No!”

Bow put his hand on her arm, but she shrugged him off. “Mom wasn’t a test subject! She was the Queen!”

“She probably became Queen after Mara sealed Etheria in Despondos,” Entrapta speculated. “And it looks like all the royal lines were based on experiments. I wonder what my ancestors looked like! Oh, we can find out about our families!”

Their families! That was right - Adora could finally find out where she was from. Where her family lived. And might still live. “Alpha! Where am I from?”

“You’re from a colonial line as well.”

“Which planet?” Where was her family?

“I would need more data for such an analysis.”

So, no luck here either. Adora still didn’t know where she was from - and if her family still lived.

“What, you don’t know where the planet of the seven-foot-tall amazons is located?” O’Neill snapped.

“There is no such planet in my databanks. And her family line is not exclusive to any one planet in the Empire.”

“And mine?” O’Neill glared at Alpha.

“Your line wasn’t exclusive to any one planet, either.”

“Great. Useless robot.” O’Neill scoffed.

“Enough!” Glimmer shook her head. “This… this… This is huge. We need to get a grip on this.”

Adora nodded.

“The origin of our species!” Entrapta beamed. “This is the biggest discovery on Etheria since magic!”

“Entrapta!” Glimmer shook her head. “People will be shocked that we are descendants of ‘test subjects’ of the First Ones.”

“And of the First Ones themselves,” Bow pointed out.

Right, Adora’s people had experimented with themselves - ‘lesser stock’, Alpha had called it. Adora pressed her lips together. That sounded… Well, what did she expect from people who were willing to destroy Etheria to win a war? They probably saw the entire planet as some experiment.

She stifled a gasp. What if they were right?

Catra’s loud scoff interrupted her thoughts. “So we’re descendants of some people used for experiments? So what? That doesn’t change anything about us. It’s ancient history!”

“‘So what’?” Glimmer turned to frown at her. “The First Ones made Mom!”

“So?” Catra met Glimmer’s eyes. “What’s the big deal?”

“The big deal is that we were made as an experiment!” Glimmer all but yelled at Adora’s lover.

“We aren’t an experiment any more. We haven’t been one for a thousand years!” Catra retorted. “We’re free!” She grinned, flashing her fangs. “And I bet we were never just an experiment. She-Ra was around before the First Ones arrived, remember?”

That was right! The First Ones hadn’t created She-Ra! That meant… “Alpha. Was there a native population before the First Ones arrived?”

“Yes. Distantly related to the First Ones. A small population.” More figures appeared on the display. They looked like Adora, walking through a village.

“Daniel? Can you identify their culture?” O’Neill asked.

"It's hard to say. The garments would fit a number of cultures in the Mediterranean. Possibly Minoans or Mycenaeans - the style could've developed from either culture." Daniel pushes his glasses up with one finger. "Although we'd need a linguist to examine their language for more clues. Or genetic samples."

"I'd prefer not to muck around with genes right now," O'Neill said.

Adora nodded - she wasn't too keen on more such revelations herself.

*****

The revelations about the origin of their species had shocked their hosts. Almost as much, it seemed, as the revelation that he was descended from the 'First Ones' had shocked the Colonel. Samantha Carter could tell. The Colonel was better at hiding his reaction than their hosts, who were openly discussing the ramifications of their descent from 'test subjects' of an alien race, but Sam knew him too well to be fooled by his attitude.

And SG-1 couldn't afford their leader having a breakdown. Not in the middle of this mission.

So she took a few steps towards him, ending up at his side, and whispered: "All of the data we have gathered so far points at the First Ones being human. Probably people taken from Earth to another planet and developing their own culture."

He turned to look at her with narrowed eyes. He wasn't fooled, either, she realised. But she stood her ground, raising her chin.

He snorted. "You heard the computer. The First Ones considered humans 'lesser stock'," he said in a low voice.

"That doesn't mean that they were genetically different enough to be considered an alien species," she pointed out. "Sir." Lots of humans considered other humans to be their lessers.

“It’s enough to make the computer single me out. And apparently, I can do magic.” He shook his head. “Magic!”

“That might merely be a talent that many humans have, which hasn’t expressed itself so far since Earth lacks magic.” If the talent was genetic - and royal families inheriting the same talent supported this hypothesis - then it was likely that humans from Earth had such talents - provided that Earth once had had magic.

“My alien heritage,” the Colonel replied in a flat voice.

“Sir, according to what we know, those people must have arrived on Earth so long ago, the majority of humanity could be related to them,” Sam said. Though that didn’t mean all of them had the same genes that apparently qualified them as First Ones. She and Daniel didn’t, after all.

“So, why didn’t you or Daniel register?” the Colonel asked. Of course, he wouldn’t have missed that.

“The human genome has a large variance. And yet we are all humans,” she said, staring at him.

He snorted again but slowly nodded. “Maybe you’re right. But I’ll still tell the doc that she missed an alien in SG-1 once we’re back on Earth.” He flashed her a grin.

She smiled in return. It wasn’t a particularly good joke, but if the Colonel was joking about it, things were improving. They would get through this.

“So!” he spoke up, raising his voice, “how does this magic work? Do I wave my hand and think electric thoughts, and lightning strikes whatever I point at?”

The others turned to look at him, interrupting their talk about how best to tell the rest of their alliance about this discovery. “It doesn’t work like that,” Glimmer told him. “You need training. Lots of training. My dad and my aunt studied magic for years before they could cast spells.”

“Unless you have a magical talent like a princess. That’s different from spellcasting and generally expresses itself as a single magical ability,” Entrapta added. “You’ll have to train to use it most effectively, but figuring out how to use it should be easy. At least it was for me.”

“Yes,” Glimmer said with a nod. “If you are a princess, you’ll figure out things easily enough.”

“Great. I might be a pretty princess.” The Colonel shook his head.

“A prince, in your case,” Glimmer told him.

“We’re just calling them princesses because the majority are female,” Catra said.

“Great. That makes it all better.” The Colonel snorted again.

“Men are included in the female term,” Daniel said. “Is this only the case for princesses or a general rule? Or do you pick the term according to what gender is the majority in any particular group?”

The others looked confused.

“On Earth, we generally use the male term for a mixed group, no matter whether or not the majority are female,” Sam explained.

“Ah.” Glimmer nodded. “It varies, but we generally go with the majority.”

“That should make a few feminists back home happy,” the Colonel said.

Sam didn’t comment.

“Well, a society with predominantly female leaders will be of quite the interest for a lot of people back home,” Daniel said earnestly. “Many models and theories can be validated.”

And a lot of people would have some issues with female leaders; Sam knew that better than most.

"Feminists?" Adora asked.

Sam saw the Colonel wince when he realised that Daniel wasn't the only one who could make a gaffe. "Feminists are people on Earth, mostly women, who work to remove gender-based inequalities," she explained. "Some of them have more extreme goals." Not nearly as many as some of the chauvinists Sam had encountered during her career claimed, though.

"Wait…" Bow frowned. "Do you mean you treat people differently based on their gender? I mean, why else would you have people trying to change that?"

"What?"

"Really?"

Sam suppressed a sigh. "Women and men are considered equals in most countries, but there are lingering prejudices and biases, which affect their actual treatment." Boy, were there lingering biases. Especially in the Armed Forces.

"We're working on it," Daniel chimed in, "but it's, ah, a work in progress."

"That makes no sense," Glimmer protested. "You don't even have magic!"

Right. Since princesses were predominantly female, they would assume magic might make them biased towards women.

"Without magic, society was dominated by men for a long stretch of our history," Daniel replied. "But things have changed. And are still changing. For the better."

Their hosts didn't look like they were happy with the explanation. Sam couldn't really blame them - she wasn't happy with it, either.

Yes, things were changing for the better, but they had a long way to go.

*****

This Earth didn't sound like a nice place, Catra thought. She knew about prejudice from the top from her time as a Horde cadet. Knew it all too well. She wasn't going to let anyone look down on her for being a woman. There were enough reasons to look down on her, anyway.

She gritted her teeth and pushed the thought away. She was changing for the better. Like Earth? She snorted at her own foolishness. This wasn't the time to dwell on that. Not when Adora looked like she was blaming herself for the First Ones crimes. Again.

Catra stepped closer to her lover. Close enough so no one could hear her whisper: "It's not your fault. Not at all. You're not responsible for your ancestors."

"But…" Adora started to object.

Catra reached up and placed her finger on Adora's lips. "No buts. This happened a thousand years ago. Long before you were born."

"We don't know that," Adora retorted, holding her hand so Catra couldn't shut her up. "The portal that brought me to Etheria might have reached back in time."

Catra rolled her eyes. Entrapta's idle speculation really wasn't helping sometimes. "Even then, you were a baby. Innocent." And then Shadow Weaver had gotten her claws into her. Into them all. The woman had a lot to answer for, but what she had done to Adora was the worst of her crimes.

"Yes, but… I can't help feeling responsible for this." Adora said, a little more loudly.

“For what?” Catra shook her head. “What’s the big deal?”

“But…”

“We - the Etherians - are the result of genetic experiments by the First Ones,” Glimmer cut in. “That’s a big deal.” Catra opened her mouth to tell her it wasn’t, but she lifted a finger and went on: “And yes, it’s been a thousand years, and we aren’t defined by our origins anyway, but… it still matters. People care about their families. Their origins.”

Catra clenched her jaws. She knew that Adora cared a lot about the fact that she didn’t know her real family - that she was taken from them by a portal thanks to Light Hope.

“My Dads will be… I don’t actually know how they’ll react,” Bow said. “They’ve studied the First Ones for so long, and now to find out about those experiments?”

“They didn’t experiment on your ancestors,” Catra told him. He didn’t look like the people they had seen in the hologram, after all.

“We don’t know that. And if we were not experimented on, we still were involved,” Bow replied.

“As a control group, probably. You can’t run such experiments properly without a control group.” Entrapta nodded.

Well, at least she didn’t have any issues with this revelation.

“We need to decide how we tell the others about this,” Glimmer said, shaking her head. “And I thought telling them about a new war would be bad.”

“Why would it be bad?” Entrapta asked. “I still don’t get it.”

“People might not like being descendants of, ah, ‘test subjects’,” O’Neill said.

Catra snorted. What did it matter? Besides, what did he know? He had trouble with the fact that he wasn't the descendant of test subjects,but of a First One! "They'll get over it," she said. "Most of them, at least."

"It's not that," Glimmer said, biting her lower lip. "But this revelation could shake the kingdoms. If our magic powers as princesses are just the result of experimentation, what does that mean for us?"

Oh. That. Catra suppressed another snort. "So? You still have the magic powers."

"Power alone isn't… enough," Glimmer retorted.

"You worry about your legitimacy," Daniel spoke up, nodding.

"No more divine right," O'Neill muttered under his breath in such a low tone, Catra was sure she was the only one of her friends to overhear him. "What a pity."

"Sir!" Carter hissed.

He was right, though. This would shake up some kingdoms. At least the weaker ones. And those ruled by stupid princesses. Probably.

"But… Etheria had magic before the First Ones arrived. She-Ra predates them, for one," Entrapta pointed out. "It would only be logical that other people had magic powers as well."

"Great. So we usurped the first princesses?" Glimmer shook her head again.

"Well…" Bow shifted a little. "That was quite common in the Age of War. At least amongst the kingdoms without a Runestone. It took time to establish a dynasty, according to my Dads."

Catra rolled her eyes. "So, you have to admit that your ancestors took power thanks to their magic? So what? You're not

responsible for them." And it was kind of funny that for all the Alliance opposing and condemning the Horde, their kingdoms had been founded in a similar way.

"Mom was already alive at the time," Glimmer pointed out. "And she never told me anything..."

Oh. That expression… Catra was familiar with that feeling as well. "She probably had a reason for that. Or she forgot."

"Mom never forgot anything! She could recite everything I did wrong," Glimmer shot back.

"Parent of the year," O'Neill mumbled.

"But things a thousand years ago? Things she might have wanted to forget?" Daniel asked.

Glimmer hesitated. "I have to ask Dad about this. And we need to tell the others of the Alliance."

"But we need to find out more about this, first!" Entrapta chimed in. "We need more data - what kind of experiments, which test subjects, what happened to them… We need to know the truth before we can tell it!" She turned to Adora and O'Neill. "And we need you for that!"

Neither Adora nor O'Neill looked happy at that.

*****

"So… now we have a baseline to analyse. Too bad we couldn't get the raw data, but the records in the main databanks should suffice for now," Entrapta said. "Why would anyone not share their research data with other scientists?"

The princess sounded as if she genuinely didn't understand, Jack O'Neill thought.

“You didn’t exactly share your research with us when you were in the Horde, did you?” Glimmer asked her.

“You didn’t ask for it to be shared,” Entrapta replied. “And it was supposed to be a secret. But this is basic research, and this is a research station, and we have two First Ones here. Why would they keep their data from others in the same project?”

Jack’s eyes widened. Wait - she had been in the Horde? Entrapta was amongst the most open and easy-going princesses they had met so far, and she was a former Hode scientist?

“You were in the Horde?” Daniel asked.

“With Hordak, yes,” Entrapta replied. “Well, I was in the Alliance, first, but then I was accidentally left behind during a mission and thought they had abandoned me, and Catra was offering me a laboratory and all those First Ones technology to study, so I joined them. That’s how I met Hordak!” She beamed at them. “And then, later, I left the Horde - well, I was kinda banished to Beast Island, where I met Micah and the others, so…” She shrugged. “It all worked out and now we’re all friends!”

Jack blinked. Catra had offered her a lab? In the Horde? That meant she had been in the Horde as well - and apparently in a rather high position. He glanced at the others. Carter was surprised as well. And Teal’c… wasn’t showing any emotion.

“Ah.” Daniel, though, didn’t seem to be fazed at all. “So, you switched allegiances several times during the war. Was that common?”

“Kinda,” Entrapta said. “At the end, it was everyone against Horde Prime. Scorpia, too.”

“Yes,” Glimmer said. “And we beat him.”

Catra was silent, Jack noticed. And Adora was holding her shoulders. Things were more complicated than he had thought.

“I, too, left the services of a false god once I had the opportunity,” Teal’c spoke up. He nodded at their hosts. “I understand.”

Catra snorted in response, but it sounded more… well, she didn’t really smile. Entrapta, however, beamed again. “Yes! Maybe we can get some Goa’uld to change sides as well!”

“Ah…” Jack grimaced. Trying to turn the snakes? He’d rather juggle hand grenades.

“There are Goa’uld who oppose the system lords. The Tok’Ra,” Daniel said. “We met one of them, but he died before we could contact them.”

Jack glanced at Carter. She was standing still, ramrod straight, lips pressed together. No doubt remembering her recent possession by Jolinar. He suppressed the urge to put his hand on her shoulder and glared at Daniel; that wasn’t how you talked about things like that.

“Oh? So they can change!” Entrapta nodded. And her friends smiled.

Great. Now they had the completely wrong impression. “We have met one individual who claimed to be a Goa’uld rebel,” Jack corrected them. “We don’t really know if he was telling the truth.”

“Oh. But the possibility remains,” Adora said, nodding firmly. “If one can turn against them, others can do so as well.”

“In theory,” Jack said.

“I trusted Jolinar,” Carter said in a clipped, tight voice. “But he didn’t tell me how to contact the others - we don’t really know anything about them. They have to operate in strict secrecy, which makes it very hard to reach them.”

“Oh. Well, once we’re starting offensive operations, they’ll probably make contact with us,” Adora said.

“Even if only so they aren’t mistaken for our enemies,” Catra added. She, too, was still tense.

“Anyway, we have data to analyse. With these records, we can track the lineage of many princesses,” Entrapta said. “And we might discover more of our past! I wonder what kind of creature had prehensile hair.” She tugged at her own hair. “Perhaps it’s a creature from another planet? Wouldn’t that be neat?”

Judging by their expressions, the others didn’t really share Entrapta’s opinion. Jack couldn’t blame them. He wasn’t happy about being part alien himself. He was an officer in the Air Force. A human. Not some… alien. Part-alien. And what would the brass think about him? Hell, some would want him removed from SG-1 for security’s sake.

And he couldn’t blame them - he’d probably ask for the same if someone else were revealed to be part alien. Especially if they arrived with other, related aliens as potential allies. Aliens with very firm views of what was acceptable amongst allies and what was not. On the other hand, if they had taken in former Horde personnel as it seemed...

Things had become really complicated. But that didn’t change the fact they had to find a way home. “So!” He clapped his hands. “Now that we’ve got the genetic data for you to analyse, how about we look for a DHD to get us home to Earth?” He noted that most others looked slightly guilty at being reminded of their original reason for entering this station in the first place.

“Right!” Entrapta said. “The concentrations of Naquadah!” She held her multitool or whatever it was up and pushed a few buttons. “It’s this way!”

“Alpha, can you show us a map of the station?” O’Neill asked.

“Yes, Colonel O’Neill.” A moment later, a 3D map of the place appeared floating above the holoprojector.

“Oh! Neat!” Entrapta cocked her head and peered at it, then at her recorder. “The concentrations are all here!” She pointed at a large room in the eastern part of the station.

The largest room in the station, actually. Jack had a feeling what they would find there.

Five minutes later, he found out he was right. The room was a hangar. And none of the concentrations of Naquadah was a Stargate. They were transport planes. Or shuttles, actually, since it was certain they could travel through space. Unfortunately, they were also all in various states of disrepair.

Not that that would deter Carter and Entrapta. Quite the contrary - both were all over the things the moment they had laid eyes on them.

“We’ll never get them away from this place in time for dinner,” he commented.

They’d be here for a while. Well, at least they wouldn’t get shot at. And they might find out a little more about Etheria’s past - both ancient and recent. Though Jack would have to keep an eye on Daniel - his friend was a little too enthusiastic about new cultures. They really didn’t need any more slips and leaks. Their reputation amongst the Etherians was probably already not the best.

Then again, as they had just found out, the Etherians had some skeletons in the closet as well. Though whether that was a good or bad thing remained to be seen.

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The Meetings

Research base Alpha, First Moon of Enchantment, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora sighed. The ships - or shuttles, as Entrapta called them - looked a little like Darla. Just a little. Same grey colour, all angled as well - but where Darla had two pods on her sides, this shuttle had none. And it was much smaller, of course; its bridge had only room for five people or so, and Adora would probably hit her head if she wasn't careful as She-Ra.

And they were all broken. At least they looked broken to Adora. One was basically just a frame, two more had their hind parts - their aft sections - dismantled, one looked like it had been shot at by a tank platoon, and the last one, the one Entrapta and Carter were checking out, looked as if it had been patched together; the colour of some parts was off a little.

"We'll never get Entrapta out of here," Catra mumbled next to her.

"Yeah," O'Neill agreed. Well, he had just said the same.

"To be fair," Daniel added, "more spaceships is a good thing, right?"

"Those are shuttles," O'Neill told him. "No hyperdrive."

"Oh."

"Do they have weapons?" Catra asked.

"Looks like they have smaller versions of Darla's guns," Bow told them as he passed them on his way to Entrapta and Carter, carrying a piece of crystal from one of the other shuttles with Glimmer. "Hidden in the bow section."

"Pointless then," Catra said. "Those won't be able to scratch a frigate's hull."

“Really?” Daniel sounded surprised.

“Those are a thousand years old. At least a thousand years old,” Catra explained.

“You could upgrade them,” Daniel said. “You did upgrade Darla, didn’t you?”

“Yes,” Catra said. “But that was mostly Entrapta’s project.”

And Hordak’s, Adora knew.

“Well, it seems this might be her new project,” O’Neill said.

Catra scoffed. “Waste of time. We don’t need shuttles. We’ve got frigates for space and orbital bombardment, and we have flyers on the ground. And tanks.”

“I wouldn’t dismiss a fast transport as useless,” O’Neill objected. “There are situations where you might need one.”

To Adora’s surprise, Catra nodded. “Right. But most of them we can probably handle with Darla.”

“Darla can’t be in two locations at once, though.”

Adora frowned. O’Neill was right again, but… that would mean letting others risk their lives in the sort of commando operation that was perfect for her and her friends. At least she couldn’t imagine any other use for shuttles that a frigate with their transporters could do as well. Of course, she could handle a war by herself, but… She-Ra was Etheria’s protector. If anyone had to go on such missions, it was her. On the other hand, if they had such shuttles, she could go on a mission without dragging Darla and her friends with her. “Good point,” she said with a faint smile. Which she lost immediately when she saw that Catra was frowning at her. “What?”

“You’re thinking stupid thoughts.”

“I’m not!” Adora protested.

“Yes, you are.” Catra took a step closer and stood in front of her, staring at her eyes. “You’re thinking of taking such a shuttle for a stupid mission, aren’t you?”

Adora blinked. How did Catra know? And how could she deny that without making it obvious that she had been thinking that?

“I know you.” Catra shook her head, then stood on the tip of her toes and grabbed Adora’s face. “And I won’t let you risk your life without me. Never again. You hear me?” She tilted her head to the side, just a little bit.

Adora opened her mouth to protest, and Catra pushed up, kissing her before she could say anything.

Oh. Adora closed her eyes and hugged her lover.

When they broke the kiss and Adora let Catra down on the floor again - she had taken her up sometime during the kiss - both of them were smiling. “But I’m She-Ra,” Adora said. “I’m supposed to protect everyone.”

“And I’m supposed to protect you from yourself, dummy.” Catra smiled, but kept staring into Adora’s eyes. She was just so… so...

O’Neill cleared his throat.

Adora jerked, but Catra just turned her head and looked at the man. “What?”

“Nothing.”

“So,” Daniel spoke up. “You were called She-Ra’s consort. Is that a formal position?”

Catra snorted. “No, that’s just Third Fleet being stupid.”

Adora nodded. “But we’re planning to marry soon.” Once things stopped coming up that they had to deal with. Such as unexpected visitors from a faraway planet with six billion people.

“We could’ve married already if you stopped listening to Glimmer,” Catra pointed out with a smirk.

Adora pouted. She wanted to get married, but she was She-Ra, Princess of Power. Glimmer had told her several times that marrying without a big ceremony and dinner would be a snub to every princess and prince who wasn’t invited.

“Listening to Glimmer?” Daniel asked.

“She wants a big wedding for us,” Catra said. “It’s political. Probably gonna be as big as the Princess Prom.”

“Ah! A state affair.” Daniel nodded. “Are there many different wedding customs on Etheria?”

Adora smiled - she had researched that ever since Catra had accepted her proposal. “Oh, yes! Every kingdom has a different way to officiate a marriage. For example, in Bright Moon, it’s an official act - you need a representative of the Queen.” Or the Queen herself, in their case. “In Plumeria, you just marry and inform others afterwards. It’s a very private ceremony. And in Salineas, you have to have a ship’s captain marry you. On the ship. And in the Kingdom of Snow, you construct a temple out of ice, before you...”

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“This is fascinating. It’s using a miniature version of Darla’s original engines! Like a tiny Darla!”

Samantha Carter resisted the urge to shake her head. Entrapta was very enthusiastic about their discovery. Sam could understand the feeling, of course, but Entrapta was… well, in a class of her own.

“Why is that fascinating? Both are First Ones designs,” Glimmer asked. The queen was leaning against the wall in the shuttle’s engine room, watching them work. Or watching Bow, as far as Sam could tell.

“Because you usually construct different engines for different ships,” Bow explained. “Just scaling down an engine generally isn’t optimal.”

“Yes!” Entrapta, held up by her hair, turned. “You lose effectiveness if you simply scale engines up and down. And sometimes, you have an explosion because the material needs a certain thickness to withstand the temperatures an engine generates. So, we can conclude that the First Ones either were bad engineers - and we know they weren’t - or they had other reasons to do this. It can’t be logistics; the parts are not interchangeable, after all. So, why did they do this?”

“Perhaps they didn’t want to spend the money for a new design,” Sam speculated. She had been stymied by short-sighted cuts to her budget before, although not often any more since she joined Stargate Command.

“Oh.” Entrapta frowned, then nodded. “Right. But that would mean that they didn’t value science very much.”

“What?” Bow asked.

“In the Horde, we didn’t have to worry about money for science,” she explained. “If I wanted something, I just asked Hordak, and I got it. Unless it was First Ones tech; those were sometimes scarce.”

Oh. Sam had wondered what had made Entrapta join the Horde. An effectively unlimited research budget might have been the reason - it would tempt anyone for a moment at least. And Entrapta did seem to be a little… off when it came to morals. At least that was Sam’s impression.

“Ah. Well, it’s not the same in the Alliance,” Bow said. “We’ve got a tight budget.”

“I know! Hordak complains about it all the time,” Entrapta said.

“Well, he’s not the Horde leader any more. He doesn’t get to rob everyone else for his projects,” Glimmer said.

“Technically, those were spoils of war,” Entrapta replied. “Or Horde production. I think. We didn’t really need much of what the Alliance produced, and First Ones tech was finder’s keeper.” She perked up. “Though if the First Fleet agrees to supply us, we’ll have a much higher budget again!”

“The First Fleet?” Glimmer looked concerned. “Supplying you?”

“Yes! They’ve got their full supply train, but they don’t have many frigates left to be supplied. So, Hordak asked if they would mind sending supplies to us. It would really speed up our research if we had better access to Horde Prime’s technology. But they are still debating.” Entrapta frowned. “They really need a leader to speed up decisions.”

“I think it’s fine if they debate and make their own decisions,” Bow said.

Sam agreed with that. She didn’t know what exactly happened on Etheria, but a former conqueror gaining more followers? Followers with a space fleet? Who were used to blindly obey their leader?

Judging by Glimmer’s expression, she wasn’t in favour of this either. “And when were you planning to tell us about this?” the queen asked.

Entrapta looked puzzled. “Should I have?”

“Yes.”

“Oh.” Entrapta shrugged. “It’s just for science. You know we’re doing research now that we don’t have to worry about the war

anymore. Although I guess that might have changed now, with the Goa'uld. Do you think we should focus on weapon technology again? I've got a few ideas, and Hordak has had a number of projects that he never had the parts to pursue until now."

"Ah…" Bow looked at Glimmer.

"I think we should discuss that with the Alliance," Glimmer said.

"Right." Entrapta nodded. "Back to tiny engines! I think I could upgrade them like I upgraded Darla's. That would make them faster."

"We'll need a lot of spare parts, though," Sam pointed out. The First Ones had been cannibalising four shuttles to repair the fifth - their supply situation must have been terrible for that to happen.

"Yes. But we can make do with Horde parts. I'm sure that Third Fleet would part with some of theirs if Adora asks them."

"That might be a good idea," Glimmer said. Bow looked confused for a moment, then nodded as well. Sam agreed as well - depriving those apparent fanatics of supplies was likely a good thing.

"Good! We might even be able to install a hyperspace engine on a shuttle if we sacrifice some space and manage to miniaturise them. Not a modern one, but Darla's old one wouldn't be too hard to shrink. We could make a tiny starship!"

"I think we should focus on our discovery here, first," Bow said. "And then on getting our new friends home."

"Right." Entrapta nodded, apparently unfazed. "That means finishing Darla's upgrades. And plot a course to Earth."

"Or to a planet with a Stargate," Sam reminded the princess.

"Yes. But we don't know where those planets are. Perhaps we'll meet some on the way. Although that might also delay us."

Entrapta pouted. “We’ll have to decide if we should just go full-speed to Earth or look for another Stargate.”

And before SG-1’s gate validation codes expired. They could contact Stargate Command through the gate using their radios, but the longer they took to open a gate, the more suspicious Stargate Command would be that they had been compromised.

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Planning Room, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“I hope you have a good reason to call for an emergency meeting of the Alliance,” Mermista complained as she entered the planning room. “I had to sacrifice my first day off after a week filled with budget meetings with the Admiralty.”

Catra suppressed a snort. For a ruling princess, Mermista was complaining a lot. Perhaps she should learn to delegate. And to scare her underlings into not annoying her. No one had bothered Catra when she had been in command. Well, Scorpia had, but that was different.

“I’m sure they had a good reason, my love!” Sea Hawk told the princess. “And we got to enjoy a trip together on the Dragon’s Daughter VIII!”

“That’s another reason they better have a good explanation,” Mermista replied - but she was smiling as she said it. So, she wasn’t really mad. Or not too mad - the princess was always grumpy. And she carried grudges. Conquer her kingdom and take her runestone one time… Catra clenched her teeth. That hadn’t been her finest hour. Even if it had been a finely planned and executed offensive.

“And good evening to you, Mermista, Sea Hawk.” Glimmer was smiling, but her tone was full of sarcasm.

“Hello!” Adora said with an honest smile. Catra nodded, as did Bow.

“Yeah, yeah, good evening. What’s this about?” Mermista took her usual seat.

“Hello, everyone!”

“Hi!”

Perfuma and Scorpia had arrived. Catra nodded at them.

“Wildcat!” Scorpia made a beeline towards her.

Catra grimaced. “Wait…”

But the other woman picked her up and swung her around. “Haven’t seen you in a while! You never visit!”

Yes, because she wasn’t keen on revisiting the Fright Zone. Too many bad memories. Catra pushed against Scorpia’s shoulders, but the princess’s grip was too strong. Without actually fighting, she couldn’t escape.

Fortunately, the woman started hugging everyone else before she broke Catra’s ribs. “She-Ra! Bow!”

“Ack!”

“Good evening.” Netossa and Spinnerella just took their seats. They looked serious - well, they were the most experienced members of the Alliance; they would expect an actual emergency.

And there was Frosta, glaring at Catra as expected. Catra smiled at the kid. Sure, she had wrecked Princess Prom, but that had mostly hurt the little princess’s ego. It wasn’t as if she had conquered her realm or something. She didn’t need to feel too bad about that - most princesses could do with some humble pie.

As everyone sat down, Catra leaned against the wall behind Adora, ignoring her lover's frown. She wasn't a princess. She was just with Adora. Sea Hawk and Bow might sit down with the princesses and King Micah, but Catra was fine standing.

"Where's Entrapta?" Netossa asked.

Glimmer sighed. "She's coming. We made a recent discovery that has her… fascinated. A discovery that has repercussions for everyone on Etheria. Actually, two discoveries."

Catra noticed that Netossa relaxed a little upon hearing that. Had she expected that Entrapta would be the reason for the emergency meeting?

"I'm not going to like either, am I?" Mermista asked.

"Probably not," Glimmer admitted. "Alright. First, remember the First Ones ruins we discovered in the Whispering Woods?"

"Yes!" Perfuma nodded. "You told me about them since it bordered my kingdom. You went and explored them?"

"Don't tell me you found another superweapon!" Mermista blurted out.

"Not quite. We found a Stargate," Glimmer told her. "A gate that connects to other gates on other planets."

"What?"

"Like the portal Hordak was building?" Scorpia asked.

"No." Glimmer looked at Bow.

"It's part of a network spanning the galaxy," he explained. "Built millions of years ago. You can connect from one gate to any other gate in the network if you know the gate address, and then you can travel to the other planet in an instant."

“Millions of years ago?” Frosta asked.

“Yes.”

“And I guess while Etheria was in Despondos, it wasn’t working,” Netossa said. “But now whoever is on the other side of such a gate has realised we’re back?”

Well, she had always been the sharpest amongst the princesses. Catra nodded.

“Yes,” Glimmer said. “And there is a war being fought out there.”

Mermista groaned. “Another war?”

“How do you know that?” Frosta asked.

“We met a group of soldiers who were travelling through the gate,” Adora told her. “They arrived here by accident.”

“And they told you about the war?” Mermista scoffed.

“Melog confirmed part of their story,” Catra said. “They’ve been fighting the Goa’uld.”

Mermista scoffed again. Catra narrowed her eyes. Melog hadn’t done anything to her.

“Anyway,” Glimmer spoke up again. “The Goa’uld are an Empire of body-snatching snakes. Small parasites that burrow into your body and take control of it. They have enslaved lots of people and rule many planets.”

“An empire of body-snatchers?” Mermista stared at them.

“Do you have proof for that?” Netossa asked. She had wrapped an arm around her wife.

Right. Spinerella would remember being controlled by Horde Prime. Catra pressed her lips together and pushed her own memories away. It was in the past. Horde Prime was dead.

"Melog confirmed that," Adora replied. "And, well… we saw one of the snakes. Well, a larva of a snake."

"We've secured the gate, so no travel is possible, so we aren't in immediate danger," Glimmer explained. "But the Goa'uld also have ships. And they want to conquer the galaxy."

"Like Horde Prime," Bow added.

"And like Horde Prime, they destroy planets that resist them," Adora said. "We can't let that happen! We have to fight them!"

Catra agreed. The Goa'uld would find Etheria sooner or later if Melog was right, and Catra would prefer to fight them on their own turf.

"We just finished a war that lasted for years!" Mermista protested. "It almost destroyed Etheria!"

"Technically, by defeating Horde Prime, Adora finished a war that had lasted a thousand years," Bow said, then cringed when everyone stared at him.

"That's not the point. The point is that…"

The door opening interrupted Mermista, and Entrapta entered. "Hi, everyone! Sorry for being late! I was showing Hordak the tech we recovered, and we kinda lost track of the time!"

Hordak? Catra tensed.

Behind Entrapta, Hordak entered the room, nodding at the princesses.

"What is *he* doing here?" Mermista blurted out.

"Providing advice, of course," Entrapta replied as she took her own seat, her hair pulling out a chair for Hordak. "So, where were we?"

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Guest Quarters, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So, team!" Jack O'Neill clapped his hands as he stepped into the centre of their room. "What did we learn today?" Carter hadn't found any listening devices, and they really needed to discuss things.

"That Etheria was once a test site for genetic experiments?" Daniel asked, looking up from his notes.

"That magic likely has a genetic component that can be manipulated by genetic engineering?" Carter added.

"That our hosts are more like us than we thought." Teal'c nodded.

Right. Joining the good guys after working for the bad guys would resonate with Teal'c. Jack shook his head. "Close but no cigar!"

"Then what did *you* learn?" Daniel asked, a little peeved.

"*We* learned that our hosts have a big fleet of spaceships but limited production capabilities," Jack said. "And a limited pool of personnel."

"Yes?" Daniel looked irritated.

"It means that Earth has something to offer," Jack explained. "We might not have magic, we might not have shiny spaceships, but we have people and industry." They wouldn't have to be the sidekick in an alliance.

"We don't know about the supply capabilities of the former Horde fleets, Sir," Carter pointed out.

"Yep, we don't," Jack admitted. "But we also know that the princesses don't really trust them. And we know that they don't know everything Horde Prime knew."

“Entrapta mentioned bots - robots,” Daniel said. “If they can mass-produce them…”

Jack waved his hand. “Yes, yes. But robots aren’t people; they can’t adapt or innovate.” At least he had never met some who did. “And we have six billion people on Earth.”

“That number really shocked them,” Daniel said. “They have had contact with other planets but were still surprised.”

“So, we have something to offer beyond our knowledge of the Stargates.” And that was important.

“And the Ancient technology,” Carter said. “First Ones technology is advanced but not as advanced as Ancient technology.”

That was a temporary advantage at most, though. Once you shared technology, it was lost. Entrapta would quickly catch up, in Jack’s opinion. But it was something to offer as well. “So, that’s the good news. Earth isn’t as far behind as we thought - except for magic. We don’t have flying, talking unicorns.” Who probably pissed rainbows.

“Or a floating magical city,” Daniel added.

“Town. Or village,” Carter corrected him. “It sounded like a university with an adjacent settlement.”

Either way, the important part was the ‘floating’. People back home wouldn’t believe this. “So, now the bad news we learned today,” Jack went on.

“Bad news?” Daniel asked. “Oh. The cultural differences between Etheria and Earth are more significant than we assumed.”

“Yes.” Jack nodded. “And that’s saying something since Etheria is ruled by magic princesses.”

“I do not think the differences are too significant,” Teal’c said. “Both Earth and Etheria are determined to fight the Goa’uld. Both

have shown honour and welcomed former enemies into their ranks. I do not see any significant problems for forming an alliance."

Jack suppressed a grimace. "Well, that's true. But there are a few things that kinda complicate matters. Like politics."

"Like the leading figures of Etheria being young women," Carter added.

Jack glanced at her. That was actually the least of their problems, in his opinion. The US had dealt with Thatcher just fine. Granted, the Iron lady hadn't been young by any means, but he didn't think the gender of She-Ra or Glimmer would be an issue once the state department got talking to them.

"They were appalled by the concept of sexism, yes," Daniel said. "But that's not the only thing." He pushed his glasses up his nose. "She-Ra and Catra are a couple. And no one acted as if this was unusual - the clones called Catra her consort. And Bow mentioned having 'Dads'. Same-sex relationships might not carry any stigma here."

Jack nodded. Unlike back home.

"I doubt that our hosts would take kindly to our practice of releasing known homosexuals from service," Daniel went on.

"Yes. That'll be a tricky thing," Jack said.

"To say the least," Carter said.

"Why would it be a problem?" Teal'c asked. "A warrior's gender or taste in mates does not affect their effectiveness in battle."

"Yeah…" Jack sighed. "That's not exactly how some of the people back home think." Certain conservative politicians would be frothing at the mouth when they heard about the 'customs' on Etheria.

"Then they are fools and should be ignored," Teal'c stated.

"If only it were so easy," Jack commented. He didn't have anything against gays, as long as no one expected him to be gay or something. Though the idea that someone might be ogling him in the locker rooms… Well, he could handle it. Still…

"And there's the reaction to magic," Daniel went on.

Right. Another hot topic. The fire and brimstone types would go ballistic. "At least there won't be any witch hunts," Jack joked.

"Actually," Daniel said, "witch hunts are still a concern in some countries. And some states have the death penalty for magic. I think the Saudi Arabians executed someone for sorcery a few years ago, though I am not sure."

Great. That was a worse problem than Jack had thought. It was the gulf war all over again - just this time, he wasn't sure if he was part of the prickly natives with archaic laws and customs or the modern allies.

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Planning Room, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Another war, where we have to rely on your clones to fight! Clones that tried once already to conquer us." Mermista leaned back and crossed her arms. "Ugh."

"Well, it will mean the clones will have something to do, other than guard Etheria," Bow pointed out.

Adora nodded. She knew that Mermista wasn't happy about having a fleet in orbit that could level her kingdom.

"Fine!" Mermista shook her head. "It's better to fight those Goa'uld far away from here, I guess."

Adora half-expected Sea Hawk to yell about an adventure amongst the stars or something, but he instead leaned closer to Mermista and whispered something into her ear that made her half-smile.

"The Kingdom of Snows cannot and will not provide many soldiers for this, though," Frosta announced. "Our soldiers aren't trained for this kind of war."

"That goes for all of us," Mermista said. "My soldiers are used to fighting on the sea, not in space."

"Not quite," Hordak spoke up. "The training the former Horde soldiers in the Fright Zone received should allow them to easily adapt to this conflict."

That was because he had formed them after Horde Prime's Horde, Adora knew. Deliver a planet and an army to his god.

"But they aren't soldiers any more," Perfuma objected. "You can't just assume that they'll go off to fight another war!"

"We can ask them, though," Entrapta said. "That doesn't hurt."

"Why would they want to go fight a war?" Perfuma shook her head.

Scorpia grimaced. "Well, some of the former Horde soldiers aren't too happy," she said, rubbing the back of her head. "They don't like working the fields or building homes."

Perfuma stared at her with her mouth half-open. "What?"

"I've heard some complaints," Scorpia said. "Nothing serious, but…" She sighed. "I think a number of them will probably join the war."

"The older ones," Catra said, nodding. "They're used to it."

And the ones who liked fighting, Adora mentally added. And those who liked hurting others.

"You should've told me!" Perfuma said.

"I, uh, was about to. But I didn't find the right moment."

"I thought everything was going well! We made such progress with the fields and orchards! And the villages! And they aren't happy?" Perfuma shook her head.

"Most are happy. Very happy!" Scorpia said. "It's just a few who grumble. And soldiers always grumble."

"They aren't supposed to be soldiers any more!"

Glimmer cleared her throat. "Anyway, we can recruit volunteers for our forces. But we'll rely on the fleets, clones and bots for the bulk of our fighting. And probably Earth forces, once we reach them and can form an alliance."

"Sounds good," Netosssa said, nodding. "But who amongst us will go fight the war? It's easy for us two" - she gestured at Spinnerella and herself - "since we don't have kingdoms to rule, but what about you?"

"I'll go!" Entrapta said. "Dryl pretty much rules itself, anyway. And the trip to Earth will be fascinating! So much new technology!" She beamed at Hordak. "You'll love it!"

He nodded at her. "I am looking forward to the challenge."

Adora winced at that. "And speaking of Earth… We need to decide who gets to travel there and negotiate an alliance."

"Glimmer has to go," Netossa said. "She is the commander of our Alliance and Queen of Bright Moon. And you have to go as well - She-Ra is the symbol of Etheria."

Both true.

“She-Ra also is the protector of Etheria,” Mermista objected. “We can’t send her away if we’re at war.”

“But She-Ra has the authority to speak for the rest of Etheria, not just the Alliance,” Bow pointed out.

“But can I speak for them? I can’t really drag them into a war,” Adora said.

“We’re already in a war according to what you found out,” Netossa retorted. “And you have a following. Not just amongst the clones.”

That didn’t mean she could or should rule them. But she could and should represent their interest. Adora slowly nodded.

Behind her, Catra sighed. But she would come with her, Adora knew. Just as Bow would not let Glimmer travel alone.

“So, the Best Friends squad for diplomacy,” Bow said.

“And us!” Entrapta said. “I need to study their technology! And Hordak is my science buddy!”

Adora could see the others exchange glances.

“Bet they’re wondering if they feel safer with Hordak and Entrapta staying here or going far away,” Catra whispered into her ear.

It wasn’t really funny, but Adora snorted anyway.

“Fine,” Mermista said. “So, Netossa will be in command of the forces here?”

“With Wrong Hordak, I suppose,” Netossa agreed.

“Yes. We’ll take Third Fleet with us,” Glimmer said.

That made everyone perk up, Adora noticed.

“Good. Anything else?”

Glimmer sighed. “Yes. We visited the First Moon of Enchantment, looking for a First Ones base. And we discovered something that might have unsettling consequences.”

“Ugh.” Mermista groaned again. “Another enemy? Another superweapon threatening to destroy the planet?”

“No.” Glimmer sighed. “It’s about the origin of us - our families.”

She had everyone’s attention now.

“We found out that the base was a research base. And their research was done on Etheria…”

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Guest Quarters, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“...and while witch hunts were often aimed at outsiders, or used as a tool to hurt rivals or enemies, many people sincerely believed that witches were real,” Daniel explained. “Tales of magic are found in almost every culture’s myths on Earth. And if our hosts are correct, then magic - powers that could achieve the deeds mentioned in the legends and myths - was once real on Earth, and not too long ago - only a few millennia, at most. We thought those tales were, if not completely fabricated, related to advanced technology used by the Goa’uld or other aliens, but this might not be the case.”

Samantha Carter, sitting on the bed next to him, nodded. “They could be related to the sort of magic powers the Etherians use.” Powers that had a genetic component, if the information they had gained today was correct.

“Yeah,” the Colonel said, “and that’s the problem. Most people don’t have issues with technology.”

“Actually,” Daniel spoke up, “there’s a not insignificant number of people who do have issues with technology, and it’s not just

minorities like the Amish. Many people feel that technology advances too quickly, leaving them unable to keep up, and..."

"Yes, yes," the Colonel interrupted him. "Computer bad, parchment good. Television bad, books good. But those people aren't going to demand that engineers are burnt at the stake. They won't be a problem when we arrive on Earth with magical princesses in tow." He paced in front of them.

When, not if. The Colonel didn't voice any doubt that they would return to Earth. Of course, that didn't mean that he actually was that certain. Sam suspected he had concerns. But as their leader, he couldn't show them. Even though everyone here knew that nothing was certain when travelling through Stargates. As their accidental arrival on Etheria proved.

"But magic - actual, honest to God, 'turn you into a newt' magic? That's going to ruffle more than a few feathers." He shook his head. "If the Etherians ever watch a televangelist, we will be fortunate if they only leave and don't decide to level his home from orbit."

Daniel laughed at that, but Sam didn't. It might not be hyperbole. "They are our best chance to win this war," she said. "We cannot afford to insult or attack them."

"Indeed," Teal'c added from where he was leaning against the wall. "It would be foolish to let superstition alienate such allies."

"That never stopped a televangelist," the Colonel said. He sighed. "And it's not even the worst thing."

Daniel looked puzzled. "What do you mean, Jack?"

"The Etherians have indicated that they do not intend to keep their presence and existence secret," Sam explained. "And if Earth is to mobilise for war, we have to reveal the Stargates." And everything that entailed.

“Yep.” The Colonel nodded. “And while many will love the fact that the Egyptian gods were aliens out to enslave us, how many will now wonder if their own gods were the same?”

“A crisis of faith,” Daniel said. “The Biblical wonders certainly would be easily duplicated with Goa’uld technology. Now that we know actual magic exists…”

“And we know there’s a magical princess who can turn a giant spaceship into a space plant,” the Colonel added. “Who is worshipped as a goddess by a bunch of fanatical clones bred for war.”

“She-Ra clearly stated that she is no goddess,” Teal’c said.

“But she displayed powers - at least to our current knowledge - that would be considered divine in many religious scriptures,” Daniel retorted.

“If all that is revealed at once, the backlash will be terrible,” the Colonel said, standing up and pacing again. “Religious nutcases will be screaming their heads off, people will be calling each other’s god a Goa’uld, half the world will be either starting a witch hunt or trying to recruit witches, there’ll be panic about being bombed from orbit by alien invaders, and people will claim their neighbours are snakes.”

“And everyone will be blaming the US for it,” Sam added.

The Colonel pressed his lips together and nodded.

“Yet the consequences of this revelation that you describe do prove the need to keep it a secret,” Teal’c said.

“Yep. But no one will care,” the Colonel told him. “They’ll all claim the US should’ve told everyone from the start about the Stargate.”

Sam pressed her lips together. That would have avoided a lot of the problems that they were now facing. It might have led to a

disaster, of course - people were not always acting rationally - but only having to deal with Etherians and magic would be far easier.

"Come on, team! We need a strategy to handle this before we arrive on Earth!"

"Jack! We're not in charge of Earth," Daniel protested. "We can't implement any policy."

"But we can make suggestions," the Colonel pointed out. "And we'll be the best experts on the Etherians. The general will listen to us."

But would the president listen to him?

"Honesty seems the best policy," Teal'c said. "The longer a secret is being kept, the more dangerous it becomes to reveal it."

"Unless you can keep it a secret for so long, everyone involved is dead from old age by the time it gets revealed," the Colonel said. "But yes - we cannot count on the Ethrians agreeing to keep this a secret. And we cannot mobilise Earth without revealing that we're in a war with aliens."

And they would have to mobilise Earth if they wanted to win this war. And be prepared for the next - Horde Prime had been stopped by the Etherians, but who knew what other conquerors were active in the galaxy?

They needed a way to handle this. And Sam couldn't think of one right now.

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Planning Room, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"We're test subjects?" Perfuma blurted out.

“Descendants of test subjects,” Bow corrected her. “Well, most of the people present.”

Most of them glanced at Hordak, of course, Catra noticed.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded with a smile. “As far as we can tell based on the data we gathered, pretty much every current royal line was the result of First Ones experiments. Originally. There’s bound to be some genetic drift over the centuries, perhaps a few new mutations, and some of the original princesses will have intermarried with the new lines, but we can track every princess in this room to an experiment!”

As Catra had expected, not everyone shared Entrapta’s enthusiasm about this discovery. She shook her head as Frosta jumped up. “That can’t be true! My family was chosen by magic to rule the kingdom!”

“That’s probably a myth that was formed - or created - to add legitimacy,” Entrapta told the kid.

“No!” Frosta glared at Entrapta. “That’s a lie!”

Catra rolled her eyes. If the princess threw a tantrum...

“Frosta,” Micah spoke up, “Entrapta isn’t lying - she’s just telling us what they found on the moon. This isn’t her fault.”

“Data doesn’t lie,” Entrapta said with a frown.

Frosta stared at Micah with wide eyes. The king smiled at her, and she sat down with a deep scowl, crossing her arms over her chest.

“I fail to see why you are getting so worked up about this,” Hordak spoke up. “Your power has not been changed in any way because of this. If anyone challenges your rule, you can easily deal with them.”

Catra winced as half the table glared at Hordak. In a way, Hordak and Entrapta were perfect for each other - both obsessed with science and research. But neither was good at reading a room or understanding others.

"Not everyone rules by force!" Mermista spat. "We're not going to fight our own people!"

Hordak frowned at that. "Why would they attack you? You are the princesses; you are bonded to the Runestones."

"It's not about power," Glimmer spoke up. "It's about legitimacy. If we are the descendants of test subjects and only became princesses thanks to the powers we received in the experiments, then some people might contest our right to rule."

"But unless they can bond to a Runestone, they'll fail," Hordak pointed out.

"Not everyone is bonded to a Runestone," Netossa told him. "Most princesses aren't. Like Spinny and I."

"You aren't ruling a kingdom anyway," Frosta snapped. "You don't have to deal with such challenges."

Right. The kid had probably advisors telling her what to do. Must have had them for years. No wonder she was so worked up about this.

"This could shake the entire society of Etheria," Glimmer said. "Unlike She-Ra, we weren't chosen by Magic - or Etheria."

"I was chosen by a sword manipulated by the First Ones," Adora pointed out with a weak smile.

Catra scoffed. "You were chosen by Etheria or magic, whatever it was, when the sword broke and you could still transform into She-Ra." Adora, of all the princesses, had nothing to worry about her legitimacy.

“But…”

“No buts.” Catra shook her head and stepped over to the round table, placing her hands on it. “This changes nothing about what kind of people you are,” she told the others. “Your ancestors don’t define you. Did you follow your father’s example?” she asked Mermista. Without giving the princess time to reply, she nodded at Perfuma. “Do you judge people for their parents’ actions?”

Perfuma shook her head. “Of course not! But can we keep ruling a kingdom that was founded on or by naked power?

“Yes?” Hordak looked more confused than ever. “You’ve been doing this for centuries, haven’t you?”

Literally, in the case of Queen Angella.

“Well,” Bow spoke up with a sheepish expression. “The ruling lines do go back centuries - to the Age of War - for most kingdoms. One could argue that the sheer time that has passed is legitimacy enough to continue your rule.”

“And our Ancestors also ended the Age of War,” Glimmer added. “They didn’t just keep fighting wars.”

“Still…” Perfuma looked torn.

“Ugh! No one will bother you!” Mermista snapped. “Your people love you!”

“As do your people, my love,” Sea Hawk was quick to say.

“My father abandoned the realm in the middle of a war!”

“As did most of your people,” he reminded her. “Yet you stayed. And triumphed.” He smiled. “No one will challenge you. And if they do, I shall smite them down for their presumption and cowardice!”

That seemed to mollify the princess. So much for not fighting her own people.

"Well, I'm mostly ruling the Fright Zone since I'm a former Force Captain and a princess," Scorpia said. "I don't think there'll be trouble - those who disagreed left already - but we're kinda an exception."

And those former Horde soldiers who left could return, Catra knew. That was a potential problem.

"Say, Glimmer," Netossa spoke up. "Did Queen Angella ever say anything about this? She was already around back when it happened, wasn't she?"

Glimmer shook her head. "She never mentioned that. She rarely spoke of her past at all. I thought she was sad about all the people she had seen die, but…" She shrugged.

"Angella rarely talked about her past," Micah said. "But that was because she didn't remember too much. Yes, she lived for centuries, but she didn't have a perfect memory." He smiled at Glimmer. "Your personal impression notwithstanding. She once told me that she had forgotten most about the past centuries and had to rely on notes and archives - just like most of us."

"The archives!" Glimmer spoke up. "Her personal notes!"

Bow and Entrapta perked up at that, Catra noted with a wry smile.

"Yes. We can search them," Micah said. "Now, I think we should talk to our guests."

"Yes." Adora nodded. "You need to meet them." She coughed, "And there are a few things you need to know about them…"

*****

The Princess Alliance

Guest Quarters, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...so Teal'c is opting for full disclosure," Jack O'Neill summed up his friend's opinion.

"Honesty is the honourable option when treating with friends." Teal'c inclined his head.

"Yeah. But there's also need to know, classified, and white lies," Jack pointed out.

"Hiding that the majority of Earth has issues with magic and same-sex relationships isn't a white lie, Jack," Daniel objected.

"I didn't say it was," Jack retorted. "But we can think of a way to present the truth in a more… manageable fashion."

"'As long as you hide your sexuality, you're fine'?"

Jack narrowed his eyes. Daniel's sarcasm wasn't very helpful. "I thought more about pointing out the progress we've made in that area."

"'In a few decades, gay people will be as accepted as women with regards to equal rights'?" Daniel looked at him over the rims of his glasses.

Jack glanced at Carter. She was carefully staring at the wall and not showing any expression. Which meant she was trying not to laugh; he knew her. He sighed. "I know it's not perfect, but we cannot alienate the nice aliens here. And just telling them everything that's… not perfect on Earth might do it."

"Earth might not be perfect, but it has many good sides," Teal'c said. "I am certain that our new allies will see that."

"Right until some religious nutcase calls for burning them at the stake for witchcraft," Daniel cut in.

"I'm sure that they have their share of nutcases as well," Jack said. "They should understand that we're not all perfect angels. We stress that we're making progress, that we've made a lot of progress…"

"Cut down on trying to turn them into democracies?" Daniel asked.

Jack glared at him. "The United States are quite pragmatic when it comes to allies." No one had tried to change Saudi Arabia, Kuwait or any of the other Gulf States into democracies, after all.

"We could tell them how we toppled democracies and replaced elected presidents with dictators," Daniel suggested.

"Daniel." Carter shook her head.

"What's wrong with you?" Jack asked with a frown. This wasn't normal.

Daniel met his stare for a moment, then sighed. "It's just… I don't want to lie to them. They are nice people. Good people. They have offered their help freely and as soon as they met us." He shook his head. "They just… they're all so idealistic."

Jack knew that. And their hosts were all so damned young. Not quite as young as Charlie would be now, but far too young for what they had gone through. And yet… "Yeah, but two of them served in the Evil Horde."

"And switched sides," Daniel retorted.

As did, apparently, the leader of the first Evil Horde. "I'm just saying that they aren't perfect, either," Jack said.

"Then they should understand that we are not perfect," Teal'c said.

Jack sighed. This was above his paygrade. He was an officer, not a politician. But Teal'c was right. Lying wouldn't help them. "So…"

A knock at the door interrupted him. "Yes?"

The door opened, and Catra entered. "Hey." She nodded at them. "The Alliance wants to talk to you. Unless you're busy," she added with a grin.

Too busy to meet what was probably this planet's Security Council? Or NATO command? While being their guests and depending on their goodwill to get home? Jack suppressed a snort. "Let's not make them wait, then."

"So, we're meeting the leaders of the Alliance?" Daniel asked as they left the room.

"Yeah," Catra replied. "All the princesses of the Alliance are present."

"Oh. Is the Alliance limited to princesses, or does it encompass others as well?"

Catra shrugged. "The majority are princesses, but there are others."

"Can they vote?"

Catra snorted. "It's not really a 'democracy'," she said. Then she frowned. "Well, I guess they do kinda vote, but it's… not formal. More like you debate and say what you think, and then there's a decision. And if you really don't like it, you can leave the Alliance, I guess."

Great. Jack frowned. That sounded like a mess just waiting to happen.

"That sounds… How did that work in a war?"

Catra chuckled. “It didn’t work very well. Not until She-Ra showed up.”

“What did she do?” Daniel asked.

But they had reached a big door, guarded by two soldiers in armour, and Catra grinned again as she opened the door. “Won the war,” she said as they stepped inside.

“Welcome, Colonel O’Neill. Captain Carter. Daniel. Teal’c.” Glimmer nodded at them. “Please have a seat.” She gestured to four seats at the round table. Which did look like a conference table that could’ve been found in any bigger organisation on Earth.

“Thank you,” Jack said. As they walked over to sit down, Glimmer introduced the new faces at the table.

“Princess Mermista, ruler of Salineas. And Sea Hawk.”

The woman - in her twenties, a little older than the rest, Jack guessed - nodded at them with a frown.

“Well met, brave soldiers!” The man stood and raised his fist to his chest. He flashed them a wide smile. For a moment, it looked as if his teeth gleamed. Mermista groaned. “Sit down, Sea Hawk,” she snapped.

“Of course, my love!”

Jack blinked for a moment.

“Different customs,” Daniel whispered.

“And these are Princess Scorpia, of the Scorpion Kingdom, and Princess Perfuma, of Plumeria.”

“Hello!”

“Be welcome!”

Whoa. That woman looked like she could wrestle Grizzlies and win. Without breaking a sweat. Or just stab them to death with her stinger. And the other looked like a hippie. There were flowers in her hair. Both were sitting closer to each other than the others. Both looked to be in their twenties.

"Princess Netossa and Spinerella."

"Hi there."

"Hello.

Another pair of adults. Neither of them was close to thirty, though, in Jack's estimation.

"Princess Frosta of the Kingdom of Snows."

Another silent nod. And she was a damn kid. If the girl was fifteen yet, Jack would eat his service cap. And she didn't have anyone sitting with her. Did they really let teenagers make decisions about war and alliances?

"And this is Hordak."

So, that was the former leader of the Evil Horde. Jack looked him over as he sat down. The alien looked like the clones they had seen before. Although he was wearing full armour. Nasty looking armour, too. Not decorative, like the Goa'uld. And he was sitting close to Entrapta.

"We have called you to discuss the situation with Earth and the Goa'uld," Glimmer said. "Our members have a few questions."

Great. Jack smiled. "We'll be happy to answer them," he lied.

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Planning Room, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...so you have six billion people?" Netossa didn't sound as if she believed it, Adora thought.

O'Neill, though, nodded with the same polite expression he had worn for the last fifteen minutes. "Yes. Though Earth isn't united - the population is split amongst about two hundred countries."

"Unevenly split," Daniel added. "The majority of the population is found in a handful of countries."

"That should facilitate negotiations." Netossa nodded.

"And you represent the most powerful kingdom on Earth?" Mermista leaned forward, her elbows on the table and her hands folded beneath her chin.

"Arguably, yes," O'Neill replied. "The United States of America are the most technologically advanced, richest and have the most powerful military."

"And you've kept the Stargate a secret." Mermista nodded.

"We've already covered that," Glimmer said.

"It's the crucial point," Mermista retorted, "How can we trust them to be open and honest with us if they don't even trust the other kingdoms on their planet? If they don't even trust their own people with the truth?"

"We didn't tell everyone everything either during the war," Adora told her.

"But our people knew at least that we were at war." Mermista didn't quite sneer, but it came close.

"Yes," Frosta spoke up. "And you don't have princesses. Not as rulers. How can we trust that you'll keep an agreement if your leader might get replaced at any time?"

“While our leaders may be replaced after an election, our countries do keep treaties regardless,” O’Neill replied. “If you can’t trust a country to keep a treaty, no one would deal with them.”

“That’s exactly the problem!” Frosta blurted out.

O’Neill smiled, but it looked a little forced. “We have a history of treaties being kept.”

Daniel coughed a few times, earning himself a glare from O’Neill and Carter. That was unfair. “Do you need a cup of herbal tea? Or a glass of water?” Adora asked. “Or are you sick? I can heal you!” she offered.

“No, no, I’m fine.”

Catra snorted, shaking her head.

“The Tau’ri have acted towards me with honour. I trust their word,” Teal’c said.

“Yeah, but you were working for the Goa’uld,” Mermista replied. “That makes your testimony a little suspect.”

Catra winced for a moment, and Adora glared at Mermista. That was uncalled for!

“Why?” Hordak asked. “Your people deserted you once as well. Do you distrust them?”

“That’s not the same!” Mermista snapped at him.

“Well…” Entrapta drawled. “It’s actually quite similar. From a logical point of view.”

“Whatever,” Glimmer spoke up. “We are in agreement that we’ll fight the Goa’uld and that we’ll protect Earth.”

“Yes!” Perfuma nodded emphatically. “We cannot let so many people be attacked and conquered - or worse!”

"Yes, but we haven't agreed on *how* we protect Earth," Mermista protested.

"We can't fight a war by ignoring potential allies," Adora said. "And while we have a fleet, we don't have nearly as many people as Earth has."

"If that's true," Frosta cut in with a frown. "No planet we know of has so many people. They claim to have over a hundred times more people than Etheria!"

"Why would they be lying? We would find out the truth as soon as we reach Earth," Bow pointed out.

"Exactly," Adora told him with a smile.

"I still have reservations. We can't form an alliance unless we know that we can trust them." Mermista looked a little mulish.

"We'll know that once we talk to their leaders," Glimmer said. "That's why we're sending a delegation."

"And because SG-1 can't agree to an alliance anyway," Catra added.

"We won't make an alliance until we're sure that we can trust the Tau'ri. You can trust *us* on that," Adora said, looking at everyone.

"Really, why are you being so difficult?" Perfuma asked, looking at Mermista and Frosta. "These people need our help!"

"Because if they betray us, they'll outnumber us a hundred to one," Netossa said. "That's kind of a worry."

"They don't have a fleet, though," Scorpia said.

"So they claim," Frosta repeated herself.

"We don't have a fleet. Believe me, we wish we had one," O'Neill said. "We don't like being so vulnerable."

“But you have advanced technology,” Hordak pointed out. “If you mobilise your entire population, you should be able to rapidly produce ships and train crews. In fact, since you haven’t done this despite it being obvious, did you check if your leaders have been compromised?”

Adora blinked - that was a good question. She looked at their guests.

O’Neill winced. “Revealing that we are at war with aliens was deemed to be too dangerous. The people would riot, panic, countries would distrust us…” He shrugged. “So far, we’ve done well enough by ourselves.”

“And do you share this view?” Catra asked. “You said you were looking for allies.”

“In our country, the military is under the command of the civilian leadership,” O’Neill replied, rather stiffly in Adora’s opinion. “It is not my place to question their decisions.

Catra smirked. “So you do think it’s stupid!”

O’Neill didn’t answer. But Carter didn’t show any expression, and Daniel hid a grin behind his hand, Catra was probably correct. Adora at least thought so.

“Great. We’re gonna have to deal with stupid rulers,” Mermista groaned.

“But at least they can be easily replaced by better leaders?” Perfuma smiled hopefully.

Judging by the way the entire SG-1 - with the obvious exception of Teal’c - winced at that. Adora was sure that this wasn’t going to work as Perfuma thought it would work.

At least it seemed Mermista had stopped being difficult.

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Samantha Carter pressed her lips together and forced herself to return to a carefully neutral expression. “That is not as easy as you think,” she said. “We have regular elections and set terms for our rulers. They cannot be removed easily.” Not democratically, at least, but she didn’t think that the princess was talking about coups and assassinations.

“I thought that you could easily replace a bad leader was part of why you have such a system,” Glimmer said.

“Some democracies can quickly change their leadership if a majority of the members of parliament agree,” Daniel said. “Not in our country, though.”

“Would be a bloody mess if that worked,” the Colonel added.

“It works for the United Kingdom,” Daniel retorted. “And for Germany, to name two examples.”

“But not for your most powerful kingdom - country,” Adora said, shaking her head. “Well, at least some bad rulers might be replaced then. That should help.” She sounded as if she was trying to convince herself, in Sam’s opinion.

“But forming an alliance is only logical,” Entrapta spoke up. “Why would anyone be against that? Especially with most of your planet defenceless against the Goa’uld?”

Sam grimaced. As did the Colonel.

“If they don’t trust us, for example,” Mermista said. “They might think we’re as bad or worse than the Goa’uld. Or that the Goa’uld don’t exist, and it’s a ploy to force them into a treaty.”

“If the Third Fleet is in orbit above your homeworld, then the lack of orbital bombardment should be proof that they do not intend to conquer you,” the former Horde leader said. “With such an overwhelming advantage, what would be gained by deceit?”

“Yeah… No. Things aren’t that simple,” the Colonel replied. “Overwhelming force isn’t always the best way to achieve your goals. And I am saying that as an Air Force colonel, mind you.”

Sam chuckled at the joke, Daniel sighed, but the others either looked confused or didn’t react at all in Teal’c’s case.

“You make it sound as if half your planet is crazy,” Frosta blurted out. That the Etherians let a child - she was barely fifteen, in Sam’s estimation - sit at the table and treated her as a sovereign ruler equal to the others said a lot about the planet’s culture. They were all so young. Sam could imagine how that would look to most politicians on Earth. Young people, especially young women… She knew how they were seen and treated.

“Well, we can sometimes give that impression,” the Colonel joked. “But no, it’s just… Very few people actually believe that aliens are real. Or magic. They will have a hard time accepting that we’re at war with snakes and allied with magical princesses.”

“That shouldn’t be a problem,” Adora said with a firm expression. “We can demonstrate that both are real.”

“And surely your word will help as well?” Perfuma asked. “Your country’s ruler is aware of the truth, isn’t he?”

“Yes.”

“And as the ruler of Earth’s most powerful country, people will listen to him, right?”

“Some will, yes,” the Colonel replied.

But they wouldn’t be happy about having been kept in the dark about the Stargate program. Especially the United Kingdom, since the Stargate was found in Egypt at the time when it was under British control.

“That’s a start.” Perfuma smiled. “We just have to convince the rest, then.”

Sam suppressed a wince. The princess sounded so earnest - and so naive, for someone who lived through and, presumably, fought in a war for years. Not naive, she corrected herself - ignorant. They didn't know anything about Earth. They lacked the experience and cultural awareness to understand the problems their arrival on Earth would cause.

They had to rectify this, or this would end in a disaster. She glanced at the Colonel; he was in command. "Sir!" she spoke up.

"Yes, Carter?" He cocked his head.

"I think we should brief our hosts extensively about the political and cultural situation on Earth."

"Yes, Jack!" Daniel chimed in, as she had known he would.

The Colonel narrowed his eyes at them both, and Sam had to suppress another wince. Telling him in public… that wasn't done. But they were in an extraordinary situation. So she met his eyes, and, after a moment, he sighed. "Well, we probably should at least explain in detail how the United States' political system works."

Daniel perked up. "I can do that, Jack!"

"An objective, neutral briefing, Daniel," the Colonel stressed.

Sam knew what he meant: A positive portrayal.

Daniel looked mulish. "I am objective."

"Remember that our hosts aren't familiar with democracy," Sam reminded him. "They don't know that it works."

"Right." Daniel sighed. "I almost forgot about the cultural preconceptions."

They were talking in low voices, but Catra was grinning at them - she probably could hear them, Sam knew. Well, this might serve

to build some trust - in a convoluted way.

“So.” Daniel stood. “Democracy. It’s a very old concept on Earth, over two thousand five hundred years old, but its form has changed a lot over the years. In Ancient Greece, it meant that every citizen of a town or country had one vote to determine the course of the polity, so...”

Sam refrained from sighing. Of course Daniel would start at the very beginning!

*****

“...and that’s roughly how checks and balances work.”

Catra rolled her eyes with a loud sigh. Daniel really didn’t know how to stop talking. She wasn’t sure if he was worse when he was asking questions or when he was lecturing.

“Catra!” Adora hissed under her breath.

“What?” Catra whispered back. “This is worse than cadet instructions.”

“Which were very useful!” Adora objected. Ever the model cadet. Even when she was very little, she had been so damn serious.

Catra grinned at the memory of Adora as a young cadet, then sighed. “Yes, yes. Eventually.”

“Eventually? This is an in-depth briefing of the government of Earth’s most powerful kingdom!”

“It’s also very long,” Catra retorted.

“Uh… do you have any questions?” Daniel asked, looking at them with an almost shy smile. “Was something not clear? I might have rambled a little, I think.”

A little? But Catra shook her head. “So, your government is based upon different factions struggling for power while keeping each other in check.”

“Ah, well, you could say that, yes.” Daniel nodded. “Although it’s really not…”

“Like the Horde then, but the leader can’t just have those who make too much trouble executed,” Catra went on. She pressed her lips together for a moment, remembering her banishing Entrapta. Not her finest hour.

“Catra!” Adora blurted out.

“What? It’s like putting the Force Captains against each other so they won’t unite and topple the leader,” Catra explained. “Only, there’s no overall commander who is above everyone else.”

“That wasn’t covered in Force Captain Orientation!” Scorpia protested. “I’ve never heard of that!”

Everyone looked at her. Catra sighed and put the palm of her hand on her face. Sometimes, she wondered how Scorpia had survived to make Force Captain in the Horde before Catra had taken over.

“Uh… It was called the Evil Horde for a reason, dear,” Perfuma said.

“We never called us that!”

“Everyone else did,” Glimmer cut in while Hordak and Entrapta were whispering about ‘official policy’. “Anyway, you have to balance different factions, one of which gets replaced every four or eight years, the other two lasting until death or retirement?”

“It’s not quite like that but, essentially, yes.”

“It’s really better than it sounds,” O’Neill added. “It has worked for hundreds of years for us.”

“A bit more than two hundred years at most, Jack.”

“That’s what I said.”

“But…”

“Two hundred years isn’t very impressive,” Frosta said. “My family has ruled the Kingdom of Snows for four times longer.”

And Queen Angella had ruled for almost a thousand years. But Catra wouldn’t mention that.

“Few monarchies on Earth were as stable,” Carter said. “And most of those are actually democracies.”

“Yes. With a figurehead.” Frosta pouted at her.

“Anyway,” Catra spoke up, “you have rules and traditions against anyone simply taking over, so that’s not an option.”

“Not for the United States,” Daniel said. “A number of other countries have suffered changes of power by force. Often repeatedly.”

“It didn’t serve them well,” Jack added. “So, that’s the United States of America. Warts and all. It’s not perfect, but it works well enough, and we’re always trying to become better.”

“I still fail to see why supporting your president to take control of the other factions and uniting the country is not an option,” Hordak said. “That’s how I started the Horde.”

“Which we beat,” Mermista snapped.

“Horde Prime arrived,” Hordak shot back.

Catra bit her lower lip. The Horde hadn’t really been beaten, despite her own… problems. They had actually been doing quite well.

"If they say it's not an option, then we have to respect that," Perfuma said. "We cannot force our own views on others."

"Right." O'Neill nodded. "No couping and no forcing regime changes. Good." He looked… not as happy as Catra would have expected. Had he planned on taking over his own country with the help of Etheria? She frowned, then shook her head. No, that didn't seem like him. It had to be something else.

"But can we actually deal with such a kingdom?" Spinnerella asked. "We would have to deal with every faction."

"Actually, foreign policies fall under the President's power. Though treaties need to be ratified by Congress," Daniel explained.

"So, we deal with the President, and then the rest of your government checks if the deal is good enough?" Mermista asked.

"Pretty much, yes."

"Great. How many countries does your planet have again?"

"Almost two hundred," Daniel told her.

"But most of them are too small to be very important," O'Neill pointed out.

"And there's the United Nations," Daniel went on. "Almost every country is a member of that organisation."

"You have a united government for your planet?" Adora asked. "Why didn't you mention that before?"

"It's not quite a government," O'Neill said.

"It was supposed to be a sort of global not-quite-government," Daniel explained. "But the way it was formed, well… It has its share of problems."

"More checks and balances?" Glimmer asked with a sigh.

"And bureaucracies," O'Neill added.

"Great." Glimmer shook her head.

"Are you really sure that having your leader take over isn't an option?" Entrapta asked. "One single leader would clearly make things more efficient."

Every one of their guests except Teal'c winced at that, Catra noted. They really had some deep issues with princesses. Or Horde leaders.

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Guest Quarters, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Well, this is a nice mess!" Jack O'Neill sighed as he sat down on the still too soft bed in their quarters. "Did you have to give our monarchist hosts ideas about couping and conquering Earth?" He looked at Daniel.

"I'm sure that Entrapta didn't mean it. The conquering Earth part," his friend replied.

"They were quite clear earlier that they didn't want to support a hypothetical conquest of Earth by your army, O'Neill," Teal'c said.

"The others were. I'm not sure Miss Mad Scientist got the message," Jack retorted. "She's buddy-buddy with the Evil Leader who tried to conquer Etheria. And she was part of his Horde." And he was sure that Hordak hadn't learned his lesson, whatever it was supposed to be.

"Adora is in a relationship with a former Horde leader as well. And another former Horde leader is a member of the Alliance," Daniel pointed out.

"And all of them wished that the president weren't held in check by Congress and the Supreme Court," Jack told him.

“To be fair, I think every American has wished the same at least once in their lives,” Daniel said. “But more importantly, I am sure she didn’t intend a coup. She thought about democratic changes in our government structures. Probably.”

“Probably.” Jack snorted. At least Daniel was honest. Sometimes too honest. On the other hand, their hosts seemed to trust him a lot, so that evened out. He glanced at Carter. She was uncharacteristically silent. Well, her little ‘suggestion’ had been a surprise. It had worked out somewhat, but Jack didn’t like how she had done it. And she knew he didn’t like it. “Carter. Your assessment.” It had been her plan, so she had to at least comment on it.

“Sir.” She briefly winced, then nodded. “I think we’ve built trust with our hosts. They are aware of the problems their arrival will cause and of the difficulties we are facing when building an alliance. If we hadn’t informed them of this in advance, it would have damaged our prospects in the long run.”

“No one trusts a liar,” Daniel added. “And they need to be warned of... well, of how Earth is.”

“You don’t need to try and scare them off Earth, though,” Jack told him.

“I didn’t. I was fair and balanced in presenting our good and bad sides. And I didn’t even mention the bigotry and racism yet,” Daniel said with a frown.

Right. The other elephant in the room. Invisible elephant for now.

“Something else we can’t put off until we reach Earth, Sir,” Carter said.

“And something that is anathema to Etheria, as far as I can tell,” Daniel added. “In my talks with them, it never came up. They might not even have a concept of hating someone just for being different.”

Jack snorted. “That’s human nature. You’ve seen how hostile some of them were. The kid and the Sea Princess are carrying grudges.”

“But those are related to the war. I never heard of any view that would be the equal to racism on Earth.”

“You didn’t notice how they view former Horde soldiers?” Jack asked. “They don’t trust either the clones or the other former Horde members.”

“But that’s not the same as hating someone just because they’re gay. Or black,” Daniel said.

“Or looking down on women.” Carter didn’t frown, but she would have if they were civilians. Jack was sure of that.

He sighed. “I know. But we can’t just tell them all the bad stuff about us. That would give the wrong impression.”

“I am sure that they will understand that Tau’ri society is not perfect but striving to improve,” Teal’c said. “They do value redemption.”

Of course Teal’c would catch that.

“They want to save the Goa’uld. Or change them,” Daniel pointed out. “That’s…”

“...terribly naive,” Jack said.

Daniel frowned at him. “I would call it idealistic, Jack.”

“Idealists are the worst,” Jack muttered.

“They seem to be genuine,” Teal’c said. “And their ideals are honourable.”

Had they gotten to Teal’c already? He hadn’t been raised in a democracy. He might not realise how dangerous and prone to

corruption monarchies were no matter who started them. “Yeah, yeah. And how will they react when they find out how not-idealistic politics are on Earth?”

“That’s why we briefed them, Sir. So they can mentally prepare.”

Which would also prepare them better for the negotiations. The State Department wouldn’t be happy if they ever realised that. “Well, they still want to take us home. And they still want to protect Earth and form an alliance,” he said. “So, it worked out. For now.”

Daniel smiled. And Teal’c nodded slowly. At least Carter didn’t smile.

Jack narrowed his eyes and stared at Daniel and Carter. “But no more such stunts. We’ll carefully plan how to tell them about the other problems they’ll face on Earth. Understood?” He wouldn’t tolerate more such surprises.

“Yes, Sir.”

“Yes, Jack.”

Teal’c nodded silently.

“Then let’s get ready for the banquet.” Jack nodded. “Carter, you have the bathroom first.”

“Sir.”

“And no sneaking off to raid the royal archives, Daniel. Behave.”

“Jack!”

“Don’t tell me that you haven’t thought about it.” Jack grinned.

“I would never break their trust like that!”

Unless Daniel thought it was necessary. Jack’s friend was an academic and a civilian, but he could be very pragmatic. Like

everyone on Jack's team.

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Royal Hall, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Compared to other feasts, this one was not much to write home about. The food was great - Adora took another serving from the roast beef - but everyone was acting subdued or annoyed.

"...and then we compensated for the stellar drift, and the remaining star systems in the data banks we copied from Alpha were quickly sorted out thanks to a spectral analysis of your sun. As we expected, Earth was amongst them! Isn't that fascinating? That our planets were linked so long ago, we don't have records of it? But now we do!"

Well, almost everyone was acting subdued. Entrapta was enthusiastically explaining to the others how they had found Earth's coordinates, with Carter and Bow nodding along.

"Indeed." Hordak sounded… not bored, but not as enthusiastic either. "How long will it take Third Fleet to reach the planet?"

"About a month at cruise speed," Entrapta replied. "We could do it faster at flank speed, but that would put a lot of strain on the engines, and while Darla could handle it - with some additional maintenance - the Horde frigates would need yard time afterwards. If they even make it that far."

Adora winced. 'Some additional maintenance' probably meant Entrapta and Bow working frantically to fix the ship and keep it from falling apart. Just like when they had set out to save Glimmer from Horde Prime. And Catra.

"Well, it would be faster if we just headed to a planet with a Stargate and took the quick route back," O'Neill said.

“If we find a Stargate that’s not guarded,” Catra retorted. “If the Goa’uld find out about us, that will cost us the strategic surprise.”

Adora nodded. “The longer they don’t know about us, the better.”

“You cannot count on the Goa’uld being ignorant of your existence,” Teal’c spoke up. “They knew about the Horde, or at least about the threat it formed - this sector was prohibited for the System Lords under Ra for a reason.”

“Because they feared Horde Prime,” Glimmer agreed.

“Or they merely didn’t want to risk a prolonged war against a peer-level opponent,” Daniel suggested.

“The snakes don’t do live and let live,” O’Neill retorted. “That’s not their style. They want to rule the galaxy.”

“Or at least the Tau’ri,” Teal’c added.

“Yeah.”

“Well, we won’t let them,” Adora told them. Letting such monsters who enslaved entire planets be? Not if she had something to say about it! And she did.

“Still, giving Earth some advance warning would be a good idea,” O’Neill went on. “So they can prepare for the fleet’s arrival. If we take one of the shuttles with us, we could head down to a planet and use the Stargate without alerting the Goa’uld.”

“Unless they spot you,” Catra told him. “The shuttles are a thousand years old. They aren’t exactly stealthy.”

“The Goa’uld technology is mostly stolen from other species and hasn’t progressed very much in the last millennia,” Carter pointed out.

“It’s still a risk,” Glimmer said.

“We could use the frigate’s transporters!” Entrapta suggested. “If we can make orbit without being detected. Which might be kinda hard if the Goa’uld have a decent patrol system.”

“Many System Lords will be expecting attacks by their rivals,” Teal’c agreed, “and be prepared accordingly.”

“We’ve beaten worse odds,” O’Neill said.

“And you’ve ended up stranded here,” Catra countered.

“The odds of that happening again aren’t very high,” O’Neill said. “It would be worth the risk.”

“We can check a few planets on the way,” Glimmer said. “But only after careful planning. We have to remain undetected.”

“Fair enough.” O’Neill shrugged.

“And if you find an unguarded Stargate, who would travel to Earth?” Mermista asked. “All of you? Anyone from us?”

Adora opened her mouth to say that she would be heading through, but Catra grabbed her thigh and pricked her skin with her claws. “Ow!” she complained, glaring at her lover.

“Third Fleet,” Catra hissed.

Oh. Right. Priest and the others wouldn’t take kindly to that. They probably would insist on sending a guard with them. Half an army.

“Whoever you want to send along,” O’Neill said. “That’s your decision.”

“Or none,” Glimmer shook her head. “We wouldn’t want to split our party.”

For some reason, O’Neill seemed amused at that.

“And it reduces the temptation for some of Earth’s leaders to take our people hostage,” Netossa added. “If they hear about a fleet

coming, some might panic."

"We wouldn't let that happen," Daniel protested. "And it would go against every treaty regarding diplomatic immunity."

"Still, it would be best to arrive as a unified party," Glimmer said.

"Or not find a Stargate at all," Catra whispered under her breath low enough so only Adora could hear her.

Well, that was out of their hands, wasn't it? Oh. Catra meant lying about not finding a Stargate. "I doubt we can fool them," Adora whispered.

"Well, not if you try to lie to them." Catra snickered.

Adora pouted at her lover. But, speaking of lies. She cleared her throat. "Also, in the interest of fostering trust, I have to reveal something we've been keeping from you until now." She stood.

The whole group immediately stared at her. And O'Neill tensed up - she could see him stop slouching in his seat. Glimmer was frowning at her, but this had to be done.

"This is my form when I am She-Ra," she went on. Taking a deep breath, she changed back. "And this is what I really look like."

SG-1 seemed shocked for a moment.

"A magical transformation!" O'Neill shook his head. "Now, you just need a theme song."

What?

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Samantha Carter stared. Such a transformation! Adora had lost more than a foot in height and much more in mass. And her long mane of golden hair had been changed to a more normal dirty blonde ponytail. How was that possible? Magic, of course. With

the power Adora had demonstrated, changing the body wouldn't be too much of a feat. Still…

"Theme song?" Adora blinked. "What do you mean?"

Oh! Carter narrowed her eyes at the Colonel. He had to go there.

"Oh, just a thing that's popular in some TV shows. A theme song," he said with a grin.

"That's a popular media on Earth. Moving pictures that tell a story," Daniel cut in. "Some of them portray magical princesses who transform to fight monsters. Not unlike yourself."

Right. Sailor Moon. Cassie loved those cartoons. Sam had had to watch them often enough when visiting the girl. Apparently, so had the Colonel.

"Although they usually do not grow in size as much as you do," Teal'c added. "Though the transformation of their clothes seems similar."

And obviously, so had Teal'c. Sam suppressed a giggle - the thought of the Colonel and Teal'c having to watch a show aimed at young girls…

"Your magical companion seems to be larger than the norm as well," Teal'c went on, nodding at Melog.

The Etherians still looked confused. Sam looked at Daniel. This was his task. If Sam had to explain Sailor Moon to aliens, the Colonel would never let her forget it.

"So, there are cartoons - animated pictures. Drawings," Daniel began. "They are quite popular with children. And some adults," he added with a glance at the Colonel.

"Hey! The Simpsons are quality entertainment for adults!"

"The Simpsons?" Catra asked with a grin.

"Jack's favourite cartoon," Daniel told her. "Anyway, amongst those cartoons, there's a genre that has magical princesses, and they are usually depicted…"

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"...which is why you reminded us of that show," Daniel finished his second lecture in a day.

"Fascinating! You use holograms for entertainment!"

"Ah… no," he said.

"It's a different technology," Samantha Carter told Entrapta. "It's not a hologram, but it uses a screen."

"Ah. Still a great idea!" Entrapta nodded eagerly.

"Oh!" Princess Mermista's consort, Seahawk, beamed at them. "Imagine a show depicting my many adventures!"

Judging by the expressions on everyone's faces, even Mermista's, they didn't like imagining that.

"Yeah, no," Glimmer said.

"We can check out those 'TV shows' on Earth!" Entrapta smiled. "And we can work out how to adapt them to our planet!"

"There are also movies. Cinema," the Colonel said with a smile. "You'll love them."

"You need to watch Star Wars," Teal'c said. "I have watched it thirteen times, and it remains as impressive and moving as it was the first time."

"Star Wars?" Adora asked, at the same time that Daniel blurted out: "*Thirteen* times?"

Which started another round of explanations.

*****

“So, this Darth Vader was the right hand of the evil Emperor. And he was hurt, so he had to wear a suit of armour that kept him alive. And in the end, he threw the Emperor down a reactor shaft.” Entrapta nodded as she summed up Teal’c’s explanation. “He’s like Hordak!”

What? Samantha Carter stared at the clone.

“I am no longer dependent on my armour for survival,” Hordak objected.

“But you were! And you threw Horde Prime down a shaft!”

“And you led an evil Horde,” Mermista remarked, shaking her head.

“We must watch Star Wars when we reach Earth! And in a theatre, so we can have the proper experience, as you explained!” the princess declared.

The Colonel had the grace to blush when Sam looked at him. This was all his fault. At least hiring a movie theatre for a screening of the trilogy would be an easy feat for the State Department. Sam hoped she would be able to watch when the Colonel had to explain the request.

But that was a thing for the future. They had more important things to worry about. She cleared her head. “So, we know the route to Earth.”

“Yeah,” the Colonel cut in, as she had known she would. “So, when are you planning to leave?”

“In a few days, once we have the fleet provisioned and ready to move,” Glimmer replied. “That will leave us enough time to look through our archives as well.”

"And enough time to modify the First Ones shuttles!" Entrapta added.

A few more days on Etheria. And then a month in space to reach Earth. Probably.

Sam really hoped they would find a Stargate on the way. Stargate Command needed advance warning of their arrival, or things would turn a little problematic. The General wouldn't be pleased in any case. Well, he certainly would be happy to know they survived, but dropping a fleet led by magical princesses in his lap?

His reaction to that wouldn't be pretty. Sam felt a little guilty that she was glad the Colonel would have to shoulder most of the blame for that. Just a little, though.

And the reaction of the government… She had half a mind to ask Entrapta if she needed another 'science buddy'. On the other hand, part of her couldn't wait to see how all the sexist politicians and generals she had met would react to the Etherians.

*****

The Farm

Royal Gardens, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Perched on a ledge on the palace wall, Catra spotted her prey almost at once. He was working out - stretching right now. But even from this spot, she could see that he had been running - his top was drenched with sweat. She looked around some more but couldn't see anyone else. There shouldn't be - Teal'c was in the guest quarters, 'meditating', Carter was with Entrapta and Hordak doing tech-stuff, and Daniel was with Glimmer in the Royal Archives. Or the private family archives. Whatever.

Perfect. She grinned as she stood, then jumped off, landing on a windowsill a bit to the side and below her. Another jump took her to a small ledge for a lantern, and then it was a safe drop to the ground.

She landed on all fours on the grass below. As she rose, O'Neill turned to face her from then yards away. "I thought the garden was off-limits to others," he said, raising his eyebrows.

She shrugged. He was correct, actually - Glimmer had ordered that to give their guests some privacy - but it wasn't as if Catra cared. Instead of answering, she looked him over. His rifle was next to him, leaning against the tree he had been using for his stretches. Close enough to grab it quickly. "Never cared much for every little rule."

He snorted at that. "Just for the important ones?"

"I focused on results." Overly so, but that was neither here nor there.

He cocked his head to the side. "In the Horde?"

"Yes."

“What I heard of the Horde didn’t make me think it was a very flexible organisation,” he said as he started some squats.

She flashed him her fangs. “It was very flexible when I was in charge.”

“Ah.” He stopped and faced her again. “You were in charge of the Horde?”

“Effectively, yes. Highest ranking Force Captain.” And she had earned it. “Directly below Hordak. And he was too busy with his research to meddle with command.”

“Must have been a cushy job. Why did you quit?”

Because everything had been rotten from the start. She forced herself to shrug and grin. “I had a disagreement with Horde Prime about general policies.”

His eyebrows rose for a moment, and she was sure he didn’t really believe her. But he nodded. “That tends to happen with megalomaniacal dictators. Sooner or later, they go off the rails.”

Oh, she knew that from first-hand experience.

“So, why did you come here? I suppose you have a gym of your own to work out.”

She shrugged. She could use the training hall for the guards. But she only did that when Adora trained. “I wanted to check on you. You’ve gone through a lot in two days.”

This time, he did snort. “You’re worried for us or about us?”

She grinned. No need to mince words or with him. “About you. You look like you can take care of yourself well enough.”

“About us? We’re just four soldiers who got lost.” He picked up one of the fluffy towels the Bright Mooners loved so much and wiped some sweat from his face and neck.

“You’ve blown up a palace before, according to your friend.” She leaned against the tree, crossing her arms. “But I’m more worried about the rest of you.”

“Little old Earth? We don’t even have a single spaceship. You’ve got three fleets.”

So they claimed. Catra wasn’t quite sure if that was true. They would have been able to recover technology. And they knew about First Ones technology - Carter certainly did. “You’ve got six billion people. And you’re afraid of their reaction to us.” And that worried her.

“Yep. It would really make things easier if you wouldn’t reveal yourself to the whole planet.” He sounded flippant, but he was serious, or so Catra thought.

“Easier for you,” she replied. “But only in the short run. The longer you lie to someone, the worse it’ll get.” Especially if you were lying to yourself.

“The longer it lasts, the more time you have to prepare for dealing with it.”

“You mean the higher the chance that someone else will have to deal with it.”

“Hey! Delegation and procrastination are the base of good leadership.”

She snorted at that. “I was never any good at either.” She tilted her head as he jumped up and grabbed a low-hanging branch to do some pull-ups.

“So, what are you worried about specifically?” he asked between pull-ups. “You hold all the cards.”

“Until you start building your own spaceships.”

“Well, by then, we’ll have kicked some Goa’uld butt together and will be friends. No need to worry.”

Catra snorted again. “Six billion people. And no princess to lead them. That’s like the biggest army ever, without a commander in chief.”

“We do have leaders.”

“Leaders elected by the people. How good would an army be if they elected their officers?” She knew the answer to that - soldiers would vote for the worst officers who let them be lazy. Or run wild. “You don’t elect your officers, do you?” She certainly hoped they weren’t that crazy.

“People aren’t an army.” He dropped down, grabbed the towel again and turned to face her. “But we had long discussions about that. So why are you here by yourself?”

That was a good question. Because Adora was busy and Catra was bored wouldn’t be a good answer. And not true either. “I’m not a princess. And I wasn’t raised with princesses, either. I was a Horde cadet since I can remember.”

He frowned for a moment, then shrugged. “And?”

“So, I’m not like my friends.” Not like Adora. She flashed her fangs at him again. “I overheard your discussion. I know that there’s more to your story and your planet.”

“Ah. And you want the truth.”

She scoffed. “Not particularly. I just want you to know that if Adora gets hurt because of you or your people, I’ll take it out on you.” She nodded at him, then jumped up, landing on the next higher branch. A few more jumps and she was on the palace wall again.

Mission accomplished.

*****

Royal Archives, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and then just down the hallway until you reach the entrance to the archives."

"Thank you." Jack O'Neill nodded at the helpful guard - a woman, like about half the guards in the palace, part of him registered - and started walking down the corridor. Seeing guards in chainmail and carrying spears on a world with spaceships in orbit still threw him off a little - it was too much like a Goa'uld palace. At least the spaceships weren't pyramids, and the hallways in the palace, while wide enough to fit two cars next to each other, weren't covered in gold and murals praising a snake. In fact, there was a distinct lack of decorations - no statues or pictures, actually.

He'd been to palaces on Earth - well, one, during a stay in England that he couldn't talk about until everyone involved had died from old age - and they tended to be a little cluttered with such stuff. Another cultural difference, as Daniel would say. Plenty of those going around.

Passing a window, he glanced outside. Two people were unloading a horse cart next to a skiff. This must have been how the country had felt back when people were still using horses to get around while planes were already carrying passengers and the mail. It would be interesting to find out how the people outside the palace lived. Perhaps he could arrange a little excursion before they left for Earth?

Two more guards, a woman and a man, stood in front of the door. "Howdy!" he greeted them with a wide smile and his best fake Texan accent.

Unfortunately, they didn't react at all. "Are you here for the archives or are you looking for someone?" the woman asked.

"Both!" He grinned at her, but she didn't react this time either.

“Your friend is inside.”

The other guard opened the door for him.

As he entered, Jack was tempted to ask them if they didn’t have to tell him not to touch anything and be on his best behaviour. He didn’t, though. Those people were just too nice and trusting for that. Or appeared to be.

Inside, he had to whistle - shelves upon shelves formed rows in a huge room, and each of them was full of scrolls, stacks of sheets, and… “Crystals?”

He cocked his head and walked forward, looking at a line of purple crystals sitting on the shelf.

“It’s a form of data storage. Obsolete, though, since a century, or so I’ve been told.”

“Hi, Daniel.” Jack nodded at him. “They told you that?”

“I asked.” Daniel smiled. “This is incredible - the records go back to the founding of the kingdom! To the day the First Ones arrived - officially arrived, I mean.”

“Well, enjoy it while you can,” Jack told him. “We’re still set to leave in a few days.”

Daniel’s face fell. For a moment, Jack worried that his friend might choose to stay. But he wouldn’t. He had never before, after all. Then Daniel smiled again. “Yes, I know. I hope we’ll be done with our search by then.”

“Good.” They needed Daniel for this. The people back home were good - the government wouldn’t have campaign donors represent them in the negotiations with Etheria - but Daniel was the one who had the best insight into their future allies. And, speaking of insight… “By the way, isn’t this anachronistic?” He nodded at the crystals. “Magical data storage, but horse-drawn carts? And spears?”

“Not at all!” Daniel beamed. “You can’t expect technology to advance just as it did on Earth. Certain technologies depend on others, but not everything is interconnected in that way. And magic, as well as different species, will completely change how a civilisation develops. Etheria had electronic - well, magical, but with similar results - communication a hundred years ago!”

“And how widespread is that?” Jack asked.

“Ah…” Daniel blushed. “I haven’t actually asked. I should.”

“Do that.” Knowing how the average commoner lived in Etheria would be very valuable to know. You couldn’t judge a country according to the palace of its king, after all. Some of the poorest countries had leaders who lived in luxury while their people starved. Jack didn’t think this was the case here, but neither did he think everyone lived in such a palace.

“Oh, by the way,” he went on. “I got a shovel talk at my age. Should I be flattered or afraid?”

“A shovel talk?” Daniel gasped.

“Yes,” Jack went on, hiding his grin. “That’s when you are threatened with death should you hurt your date.”

“I know what a shovel talk is, Jack!” Daniel bristled. “But why did you get one? What did you do?”

Jack snorted. “Nothing like that. Catra just warned me that if Adora gets hurt because of something on Earth, she’ll take it out on me.”

“What?” Daniel stared at him.

“What? What did she do?”

Oh damn… Queen Glimmer had been on the other side of the shelves. Time for damage control. “She was joking,” Jack quickly said.

“Was she? Even if she were, that’s not how you treat a guest!” Glimmer scoffed through clenched teeth. “I’ll talk to her. And I’m sorry about this!”

“It’s nothing. She’s just looking out for her girlfriend,” Jack said.

“It isn’t nothing!” Glimmer insisted. “And she should’ve known better.” She sighed. “I’ll handle this.”

Oh, damn. Jack felt like a tattletale. “Really, it’s nothing,” he repeated himself. “I understand where she’s coming from.”

And now Glimmer was looking at him with narrowed eyes. “You do?”

“Don’t you feel protective of your friends?”

“Of course I do!” she replied. “But that doesn’t mean I threaten guests without any reason!”

Well, whether or not Catra had a reason was debatable. Jack clenched his teeth for a moment. How to handle this? Hadn’t Catra talked to Glimmer about what she heard? “It’s not all sunshine and rainbows on Earth,” he said. “She’s got a reason to be concerned - we have a lot of differences, after all.” More than they knew.

“We know that,” Glimmer said.

“But also many things that we share,” Daniel cut in.

Jack refrained from asking what exactly, other than a desire to kick snake butt and help their victims.

“Well, of course we do,” Glimmer said. “Even if you have a weird system for governing your kingdoms - your countries. And you don’t have stage plays, but those ‘movies’.”

“We do have stage plays,” Daniel said. “And concerts. Both are quite popular.”

“You do?” Glimmer smiled. “That’s a relief. We thought that all that you did for entertainment was staring at a screen.”

“Don’t knock it until you’ve tried it!” Jack protested - but with a grin. Situation defused? “Anyway, we’ve got six billion people, which means our fair share of idiots is much bigger than yours.”

“In total numbers,” Daniel explained.

Jack frowned at him. Judging by the way Glimmer pursed her lips, she didn’t like being talked down to, even by accident. Well, few people did. And she was royalty. “Anyway, don’t, ah, scold her, OK? It’s really no big deal. I probably would do the same thing in her place if I was worried for my team.”

Glimmer snorted. “There’s always a reason to scold her.” But she was smiling. “So, what brings you here?”

“Oh, I wanted to check up on Daniel. Maybe drag him out to see the sun for an hour or two. Take a trip through the countryside before we get stuck in a spaceship for a month?”

“Oh!” Glimmer blinked. “That’s right - we’ve been here for hours!”

“That’s not a problem!” Daniel reassured her. “I love this!”

“Yes, you do,” Jack agreed. “But it’s not healthy to stay inside all day.”

Daniel stared at him, then frowned. Jack kept smiling at his friend. Yes, I need you outside, he thought. Come on, pick up the hint!

“I guess a break wouldn’t go amiss,” Daniel said with obvious reluctance. “And you might be needed for, well, ruling?” he asked the queen.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “Dad should be able to handle it. He will have to when we leave for Earth. But I guess a break sounds fine.” She looked at the crystal in her hand and shook her head.

Possibly troublesome information? Jack wondered. Not that he'd ask the queen right now.

Glimmer sighed, then smiled. "I'll ask Adora to be your guide. She must be all worked up about planning and logistics by now."

"Thank you," Jack said. He would have preferred to walk around without a 'guide', but he couldn't fault their hosts for being cautious. And, he added to himself, with all the magical creatures around, maybe there were monsters to be wary of outside the city.

Getting ripped apart by an alien Killer Rabbit of Caerbannog because Jack didn't recognise the threat until it was too late would be an embarrassing way to die.

*****

Outside the Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So, where do you want to go?" Adora asked with the best smile she could manage as they stepped through the gate. She didn't need to take a break no matter what Glimmer had said. Not when they still had so much to plan for their expedition. They would be gone for months, and that required extensive planning to cover all eventualities! She had barely gone through everything that was needed in case they all lost their engines at the same time.

Catra, walking and stretching at the same time, snorted.

Adora frowned at her. Her lover, of course, had agreed with Glimmer - but only so she could take a break as well.

"Well, I was always fond of the countryside," O'Neill told them. "You know, farmlands and such. Makes me feel nostalgic."

"You want to compare farms," Catra said with another snort.

“Well… I’m curious, yes,” he admitted. “We don’t have magic at home, so I wonder how that changes things.”

Daniel nodded after a moment. That was a little weird - he was usually much quicker.

But Adora could show them farmland easily. “Most farms are near Bright Moon,” she explained as they walked over to a skiff. “The Whispering Woods aren’t good for farming - too many monsters venture out of them - though Plumeria manages well enough in their part.”

“That’s because Perfuma controls the plants,” Catra said.

Adora sent her another frown. She had been about to explain that! “Anyway, the farms surround Bright Moon.” She had already said that, damn. “Most produce, uh, vegetables. And they have cows.”

“Ah. Where do you get your grain?” Daniel asked.

“Mostly through trade, I think,” Adora said.

“Trade from the plains before they turn into the Crimson Waste,” Catra added. At Adora’s surprised glance, she grinned. “I was planning to cut you off from that supply once. Decided against it since Perfuma could have made up the difference easily.”

Adora blinked, then frowned at her lover. Did she have to bring her Horde past up?

“Ah. That would facilitate logistics,” O’Neill said.

“But if they could replace your grain source, why don’t they do it?” Daniel asked. “They could make a profit, right?”

They could, but… “Perfuma’s busy helping Scorpia,” Adora explained. “And she wouldn’t want to hurt the farmers in the plains.”

“Ah.”

“That’s good to know,” O’Neill said. “So, where is the next farm?”

“Get on, I’ll drive us there,” Adora told him, pointing at the skiff. She knew a few farms - well, she had seen them while travelling to and from Bright Moon. It wouldn’t be hard to find one.

“Do you know the farmer?” O’Neill asked as they climbed into the skiff. Well, Catra showed off and entered with two jumps. At least she hadn’t scratched the hull this time.

“No,” Adora told him as she took her position at the controls. Catra joined her, as expected.

“We don’t have to visit the closest farm if there’s a farmer you know a bit further away,” O’Neill said. He was standing near the bow.

“Ah, sorry, I don’t know any farmer,” Adora replied. She might have met some at one of the festivals, but she wouldn’t be able to tell if they were farmers, of course. Bow had a brother who was a farmer, but Adora had never met him, and his farm wasn’t near Bright Moon anyway. At least as far as she knew. “But it shouldn’t be a problem; everyone I met was very friendly. They won’t mind showing you their farm.” At least they shouldn’t.

“Ah.” O’Neill looked at Daniel, who seemed to be frowning.

“Is something wrong?” Adora asked while she guided the skiff next to the road - you didn’t drive on the road with a skiff, after all.

“Nothing.” O’Neill smiled. “Daniel’s grumpy because he wanted to spend more time in the dark cellars of the palace, staring at mouldy books.”

“It is a bright, well-illuminated archive, and there’s no speck of mould in sight!” Daniel protested.

“Ah.” Adora smiled. The two were friends and joking around with each other. Just like Catra and Adora had, back when they had been cadets.

But Catra was narrowing her eyes at the two, Adora noticed. So, something was wrong.

“We’re not exactly involved with farming,” Catra said, leaning against the railing. “We were raised as cadets in the Horde.”

“So I gathered,” O’Neill replied.

“Do you know any farmers back on Earth?” Catra asked.

“Neighbours of my parents,” he told them.

“Ah.” Catra grinned again. O’Neill smiled back, showing his teeth.

“As I said, I don’t think they’ll mind showing you around,” Adora repeated herself. “Whether we know them or not.”

“Unless you wear a Horde uniform,” Catra added.

“Well, we don’t,” O’Neill said.

“Is the symbol still in use?” Daniel asked.

“Not officially, but a lot of people are wearing their old uniforms. Even Adora does it,” Catra said.

Adora frowned at her for a moment before paying attention to the road again. She had removed the Horde symbol, but the uniform was just too comfortable. And practical. Bright Moon’s clothes felt a little off. “It’s a very good uniform,” she defended herself. “And you’re wearing your old one too!”

“I’m wearing it since it annoys Glimmer,” Catra replied with a grin.

“You two don’t get along?” Daniel asked.

“They do,” Adora said at once. “They just like annoying each other.”

Catra snorted again. “We have an understanding.”

“Ah.”

“There’s the farm!” Adora pointed out. She could see the fields on both sides of the road and the farmhouse a bit away.

“It looks new,” Daniel said.

It did. “The old one was probably damaged or destroyed during the war,” Adora said.

“Probably. I think I sent a tank platoon through this area,” Catra added.

Adora frowned. Did she have to remind everyone of her past in the Horde every day? And act as if she were proud of it at times? Adora remembered that battle. And not too fondly, even though the Alliance had come together as one here.

“That would have torn up the fields,” O’Neill said, looking down.

“Hovertanks,” Catra told him. “They don’t touch the ground.”

“Ah.” O’Neill nodded. “That’s easier on the countryside.”

“But they might have flattened the house anyway,” Catra went on. Adora pressed her lips together. There she went again.

“Bad drivers or standing orders?”

“Both. Anyone could hide with a grenade in the house.”

“Well, either way, it was rebuilt,” Adora said as they came to a stop near the main house. “Hello!” she yelled as she jumped down from the skiff.

A young man came out of the house, wiping his hands on an apron. "Who is… She-Ra!" He gaped at her.

She smiled at him in return. "Hi! Our guests here said they were interested in seeing a farm, so I wanted to ask if they could take a look at yours."

"We're not planning to take up farming," O'Neill added. "We're just curious how it compares to our own country."

"Of course!" the man blurted out. "Jesa is working in the fields, but I can give you a tour here. What do you want to see? Ah, I'm Ketro."

"Just show us around," O'Neill said. "No need to make a production out of it."

"Ah. Well, here's the barn, and there's the stable. It's empty right now since Jesa is using the plough and the cows are on the field. And there is our well. Over there…"

Adora smiled. This was going well. And Ketro didn't seem to mind Catra, either, which had been a worry for her.

*****

Laboratory No 2, Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and if we replace this part here with a smaller, more efficient one, we gain the space to add a second booster unit here! Do you see?" Entrapta asked with a smile.

Hordak nodded. "Yes, I see. Very good. But we need to compensate for the reduced redundancy in case there is a power fluctuation."

"Oh, yes. But we can handle that with a better power supply that can store the excess power as well. We just need a dual-way

regulator here.” Entrapta’s hair strand twisted and pointed at the main crystal array.

Or at least what had been the main crystal array - Sam Carter wasn’t sure any more whether the secondary array hadn’t eclipsed the main array’s capacity after all the modifications they had done. And speaking of modifications… “But can it handle fluctuations quickly enough?” she asked.

Hordak frowned at her, but Entrapta nodded. “Good question! We have to reinforce all power lines to compensate for the possible delay.”

“Unless we use the improved regulator,” Hordak said.

“But that model isn’t ready…” Entrapta’s eyes widened. “Did you finish it?”

Hordak’s pale, alien face twisted into a smile. “I did.”

“How did you manage to solve the synchronisation issues?” Entrapta cocked her head sideways.

“I replaced the control crystal with a more advanced one that could anticipate more requests So…”

“...it’s always ready to reverse the flow even as it feeds the engine! That’s perfect, Hordak!” Entrapta’s hair lifted her up, letting her hug Hordak.

The alien’s smile grew a little more… a little softer? Sam couldn’t really tell. “I would say adequate. Perfection is… overrated,” he said.

Entrapta’s smile grew softer as well as she nodded. “Yes.”

Sam was sure she was missing something. But asking for an explanation right now? Interrupting the two felt rude. The Colonel would do it anyway, of course, but Sam wasn’t him.

She still cleared her throat after a short while. "So, with those changes to the engine, do we need to adjust the controls as well?"

Entrapta blinked and released Hordak before turning to look at Sam. "Oh, yes! We need to update the controls, or the automated security programs will not allow the shuttle to use the improved engines. Silly limiters!"

Limiters generally had a reason, in Sam's experience. If the shuttles had been meant for civilian use, it made sense to regulate the engine's output so it wouldn't go past safe levels. For a combat craft, though? A military pilot was expected to handle such a challenge easily - and would be needing the full power at one point at least, no matter the risk or strain.

"And we need to make a note in the manual," Hordak went on.

"Right! Someone other than us will be flying this shuttle!" Entrapta nodded. "So, let's do it! Come on, lab buddy!" She dragged Hordak along with her hair.

Or, Sam amended her thought, Hordak let himself be dragged along. He was strong enough, according to Sam's estimates based on seeing him work on the shuttle, to resist Entrapta.

But he wouldn't. Sam was sure - the former Horde leader hadn't quite ignored Sam, but his attention had always been on Entrapta. Was that how Entrapta had been convinced to join the Horde? She had said it had been Catra who had offered her a lab, Sam remembered. And neither Hordak nor Entrapta struck her as the type to seduce an enemy into joining them. Still…

She shook her head. She was here to work on the First Ones shuttle, not to speculate about a workplace romance between a magical princess and an alien warlord. And she certainly wasn't here to wonder whether or not this had happened while Entrapta had been Hordak's subordinate and scientist. She wouldn't touch that thought in a hazmat suit!

No, she would do what she did best: Focus on the technology and learn as much as she could while she had the opportunity. Personal relationships could wait. A long time.

*****

Guest Quarters, Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and the farmers, even though they are living right next to the capital, use animals to pull the plough and other large farming tools," Daniel said. "Obviously, they haven't mechanised agriculture so far. Though with magic, they probably don't need to."

"The fields are too big to be handled by a single draft animal," the Colonel added. Samantha Carter raised her eyebrows at him, and he grinned. "I grew up with farmers as neighbours."

She filed that bit of information away as she nodded.

"Yes, Jack. But they manage to tend to those fields. So that means either their draft animals are much more efficient than Earth's, or they use magic to compensate. Somehow." Daniel shook his head. "Though I don't see how that would work."

The Colonel grinned. "See? Isn't that more interesting than mouldy old records?"

"They aren't mouldy!" Daniel snapped. Then he sighed. "But yes, we did find out more about Etheria's society - well, Bright Moon's. They don't have mass media as we do. Ketro and Jesa have a communication tablet, but it's mostly used as a telephone with video. The palace apparently can use the network to give out warnings and other information, but they don't use it for entertainment."

"So, the state controls the news - what passes for news here," the Colonel said.

"For now," Daniel replied. "Glimmer is interested in our media, so this might change. She was talking about adapting our entertainment media."

"Then let's hope that daytime TV won't kill Etherian agriculture," the Colonel joked. He grew serious quickly, though. "Other than the video phone thing, the farm wasn't very advanced. Could've been taken straight out of the 1930s on Earth."

Sam nodded. "Such technological discrepancies aren't uncommon on Earth either," she pointed out.

"They aren't, no. But not in developed countries," Daniel said. "If Bright Moon is their most advanced country, then contact with Earth will be more disruptive than we thought."

The Colonel nodded. Sam agreed as well.

This could be a problem.

*****

Planning Room, Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and logistics look good. Third Fleet should have stocked up on provisions by tomorrow," Bow said. "They are eager to escort us."

Catra snorted as she saw Adora wince at the comment. Her lover had left talking to Priest and his clones to Bow and the others and felt guilty about it. Typical! As if her friends didn't know how uncomfortable talking to those clones made her feel!

"Sorry…" Adora said. "I was busy."

Bow smiled at her. "We know - you showed our guests around."

"Kept an eye on them as they scouted your farms," Catra corrected him.

“Catra! They were just curious!” Adora said with a pout.

“Very curious,” Catra agreed with a snort.

“Besides, what is to scout there? It’s not as if we’re hiding the fields. Even if we wanted to, we couldn’t. Nor the barns.

“Actually, between Perfuma and Entrapta, I’m pretty sure we could create underground farms,” Catra told her. “But that wasn’t what I was thinking about. They were curious about the farmers.” At least O’Neill had been.

“So? That’s a good thing, meeting more people,” Adora said.

“They are a little odd about princesses,” Glimmer added with a nod.

“Odd? How so? I didn’t notice anything odd,” Entrapta said with a frown. “Sam is a great scientist!”

Hordak tilted his head slightly. “She’s skilled. But she doesn't have much experience with our technology.”

Are you jealous? Catra wondered privately. Or just concerned? As if he had to worry about Entrapta falling for someone else; Catra’s friend was head over heels for Hordak. But that was a topic for another day. “You know how they are about their ‘democracy’; they wanted to find out how you treat farmers,” she explained. “Whether we treat them like the Horde or not.”

“Oh!”

Glimmer scowled. “Who do they think we are?”

“They have certain preconceptions about princesses,” Bow said. “Based on their own planet and the Goa’uld.”

“Well, they better lose them if this Alliance is going to work out,” Glimmer retorted. “So, did their visit go well?”

“Yes,” Adora said, nodding firmly. “Ketro and Jesa liked them, too.”

“Good. They’re good people, too. Anyway, we’re ready to leave as soon as Darla is ready,” Glimmer said. “Dad’ll handle Bright Moon in my absence.”

King Micah nodded. “We’ve informed the staff.”

“We still need some time to get the shuttles modified - well, one of them,” Entrapta said. “We might need her if we want to visit a Goa’uld planet. I am thinking of calling her Delia. Hordak told me that ‘Tiny Darla’ would be misleading.”

Right. Catra pressed her lips together. She wouldn’t mind skipping all those planets and not giving Earth a lot of time to prepare for their arrival. Less chance of them hiding something important. On the other hand, if their people really would be shocked by the existence of other planets, maybe a little warning would be good. Enough to avoid the worst, but not enough to fool Adora and the rest.

“Can you do it in a day?” Glimmer asked.

“Uh… It wouldn’t be as good as it could be,” Entrapta said. “We’ve got some ideas about a stealth system upgrade.”

“You can tinker with it on the trip to Earth, can’t you?” Glimmer looked at her.

“Well, yes. Though we would have to take more parts with us.”

“Please do it.” Glimmer nodded. “I want to leave tomorrow.”

And if Entrapta was busy working on the shuttle, she was less likely to modify Darla literally on the fly.

“Why the rush?” Bow asked. “Is this about the archives?”

Glimmer pressed her lips together in return. So, it was about Queen Angella’s diaries. Catra suppressed the guilt she felt - the

former Queen was lost because of Catra's plan to win the war. A rather foolish plan, all things told, that had almost doomed them all and had led to Entrapta almost dying on Beast Island…

A hand on her thigh interrupted her thoughts. Adora. Catra snorted softly and nodded at her lover. She was fine.

Adora frowned slightly but nodded back.

"I've read through several entries," Glimmer said, "and Mom didn't mention any experiments. She also didn't mention any war to take over Bright Moon's land."

"She founded Bright Moon," King Micah said. "That is known."

"Yes. But was it a wilderness? Or another, earlier kingdom?" Glimmer shook her head. "I can't tell either way. Mom didn't say anything about it."

"There might be other entries," Bow suggested. "You only looked for half a day."

"Which was O'Neill's fault," Glimmer grumbled. "But going through the entire archive will take weeks. Weeks we don't have to spare. Not with a war looming."

"The Goa'uld don't know that we're about to fight them," Adora said.

"We can't count on that," Catra pointed out. "Not only might they strike at Earth at any moment, but they might regularly probe our sector or have spies planted on some planets." She certainly wouldn't have ignored a threat like Horde Prime - she would have had her troops keep an eye on him.

"Could they have spies on Etheria?" Entrapta asked.

"No. We were in Despondos for a thousand years," Glimmer said. "Any spies would be long dead."

“They could’ve hidden amongst us and survived so long by taking over other people,” Bow said.

“For a thousand years? Never trying to take over a kingdom?” Glimmer shook her head.

“Maybe they have, and we never noticed,” Entrapta speculated.

“Great. More things we need to search in the archives!” Glimmer cursed under her breath. Angella’s records must be something disturbing, then.

“Well, even if they had spies on Etheria in Mara’s time, they might not be loyal to the Goa’uld any more,” Catra said. “They might have gone native - or deserted.” Like Double Trouble. Oh. “We should probably keep an eye on Double Trouble, though,” she said.

“Double Trouble? Do you really think they could be a spy for the Goa’uld?” Bow asked.

Sometimes he was just too naive.

“They would betray us in a heartbeat, as long as they think it would be fun,” Glimmer said. “Remember how they vanished the first time?”

Catra nodded. She was biased, but she knew that you couldn’t trust that spy.

“But finding them will be hard,” Glimmer went on.

“We will do our best,” King Micah cut on. “Don’t worry about it.”

Catra was sure Glimmer would worry, of course. The princess had some issues with delegation.

Not that it mattered - since they were leaving for Earth in a day, she would have to leave that to others.

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Courtyard, Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

The Etherians were no slouches, Jack O'Neill had to admit. When he had seen the amount of supplies they had readied for Darla, he had worried they'd be loading for days - they didn't have containers, or so it seemed, and he hadn't seen any cranes - but the big hulking half-scorpion-woman, Scorpia, and Adora in her magical amazon form, were making short work of that. The sun was still up, and the ship was, supposedly, almost ready to lift off.

He looked at his team. Teal'c was standing straight and not showing any emotion. Jack hadn't expected anything else. Carter was helping with last-minute adjustments of the shuttle, off to the side. And Daniel was… sulking. Jack snorted. "Cheer up, Daniel! You'll get more chances to visit!"

"But when? I doubt we'll be sent back to Etheria to search their archives, what with the war and all."

"The information will keep. Patience, young grasshopper," Jack told him. "Or: Priorities!" he added with a grin.

Daniel's glare deepened. "This information could give us crucial insight and information about the First Ones and their technology!"

"Then you can bet that General Hammond will send you back as soon as possible."

"Indeed. The General is very pragmatic."

"'As soon as possible'!" Daniel spat. "I've heard that before."

Right. He had heard something similar about saving his wife. Jack suppressed a grimace. "Come on, cheer up!" he repeated himself. "Wouldn't want our guests to worry that they might have accidentally offended you."

“I think they’ll understand my frustration,” Daniel retorted.

They probably would, Jack agreed. The princesses did seem to place a lot of importance on friendship. Which was a recipe for nepotism, of course, but it meant Daniel would have an easier time earning their trust. He shrugged. “And they want to win this war as well, so they’ll prioritise accordingly.” At least Jack hoped they would - he wasn’t quite sure about some of them. And Hordak… Jack carefully didn’t clench his teeth as he watched the alien walk up the ramp of the spaceship.

Cheers from the shuttle to the side drew his attention. Was that Carter in the cockpit? It was!

The shuttle slowly started to float, about a yard above the ground, then turned towards the loading ramp of Darla. Jack held his breath for a moment - he trusted his team with his life. And with his car, if they needed it. But piloting a ship that size up a ramp and into a spaceship? Carter was a pilot, but she had never piloted this kind of ship! But she was Carter. A genius.

So he watched as the shuttle vanished into the spaceship without the tell-tale sounds of metal hitting metal. She was the smartest woman he had ever met. One of the most beautiful ones, too. And the bravest by far.

And she was his subordinate, and he wouldn’t even think of anything beyond that. They were both professionals. And they knew the rules. So, nothing could happen. And nothing would happen.

He sighed.

“Don’t tell me that you suddenly want to stay!” Daniel blurted out. A little hopefully, too.

Jack snorted. “Just feeling a little nostalgic,” he lied. “Let’s go over to the others.”

Now that the ramp was clear again, Adora was just lifting up another crate of supplies while Scorpia had already one on her shoulders.

"I guess if the shuttle hadn't been able to fly, you could've just carried it up the ramp, huh?" Jack joked as he approached the princesses.

Adora wrinkled her nose. "I actually don't know how much the shuttle weighs."

"More than a tank?" Scorpia asked. "I guess so. We'd probably have to carry it together then!"

Adora nodded. Probably yes.

Jack blinked. "Are you serious?" They couldn't be serious, could they? They had been carrying heavy crates without effort, but a shuttle? Or a tank?

"Well, when I was mind-controlled by Horde Prime, I threw a tank at Adora," Scorpia said.

"Yeah." Adora frowned. "And I wasn't allowed to throw one back."

Both laughed. But Jack had the distinct feeling that they weren't joking. He glanced at his friends. Daniel was staring as well, his mouth slightly open. Teal'c was unflappable, of course. "Well, you could try to lift the shuttle in the hangar inside," Jack said with a grin. "Wouldn't want to find out in the field that you can't carry it."

"Good idea!" Adora smiled. "Let's check it!" She lifted her crate on her shoulder and hurried up the ramp, followed by Scorpia.

"You were joking, Jack, weren't you?" Daniel asked.

"Let's just go and watch what happens," Jack told him, stepping on the ramp.

"Jack."

“Daniel.”

“We have not seen the tanks they threw around,” Teal’c pointed out as they entered the ship. “There is a significant difference between a light tank and a main battle tank.”

“Yeah,” Jack said. But even throwing a bloody M-3 Stuart around would be a huge feat.

Then he saw Adora lifting one side of the shuttle. She was grunting and straining, but she was lifting it.

Damn. “DC will sue for copyright infringement,” he muttered. “Supergirl is trademarked.”

“Jack!” Daniel hissed.

“What?” Jack stared at him. “It has to be Supergirl. Power Girl got short hair.” And a bigger bust.

“That’s not the point!”

Of course it wasn’t. But Jack didn’t want to think about what he had just seen here.

At least Carter seemed to be shocked as well.

Jack had never thought that their trip home would be boring. But he wouldn’t mind a few surprises less. Not at all.

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The Departure

Courtyard, Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, July 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

The shuttle was heavy - too heavy to easily lift. And Adora didn't have the leverage to lift it, anyway. But she should be able to drag it, in a pinch, if they could rig some sledge or something. And it was good to know that.

She smiled at O'Neill. Then she noticed that he was staring at her. Had he expected her to lift the shuttle? Well, she couldn't beat physics! "Alright, now let's secure it!" she said. "We want to lift off on schedule!"

"Alright-y!" Entrapta's hair started to push buttons, and the shuttle seemed to freeze to the floor. "Magnetic clamps!"

Ah. Adora nodded. "Let's get the rest of the supplies."

"OK!" Scorpia followed her out of the ship. The four crates left took them two trips - you had to be careful with the parts Entrapta and Hordak were bringing.

"Alright! Everyone, to the bridge!" Entrapta said. Then she blinked. "Or to the ramp to say goodbye, I guess."

Glimmer's dad was waiting there, with the rest of the Alliance. Even Frosta was there, though she was scowling. Which made her look adorable, not that Adora would ever tell her that.

"Dad." Glimmer hugged Micah, closing her eyes.

"Be safe, Glimmer."

"Be brave!" Sea Hawk raised his fist to the sky. "You're going on the greatest adventure ye..oh!"

“Don’t scream,” Mermista told him after elbowing his gut. “And you! Don’t get killed!”

“We won’t, “Adora said. She would make sure of that.

“Not if we can help it,” Catra added with a snort.

Perfuma, one arm wrapped around Scorpia’s waist - as far as she could manage, at least - smiled at them as well. “And tell me about new plants and animals you meet.”

Right. That was a good idea. Earth would have many exotic plants and animals. “We’ll bring you back some seeds!” Adora told her.

“Ah…” Bow scratched his head. “That might not be a good idea…”

“I can keep them safe,” Perfuma told him.

“Good.” He nodded.

“Safe?” Adora wondered.

“Foreign plants - or animals - unbalance nature,” Perfuma explained. “It happened before, on a smaller scale, on Etheria, when new plants were introduced to an area.”

“Oh.” Adora hadn’t thought about that.

“They didn’t cover that in Force Captain Orientation,” Scorpia said.

“That’s because we tended to log the trees and crush the rest,” Catra said.

“Which we don’t do any more.” Perfuma smiled. “Anyway, safe travels.”

“Thank you.” Adora hugged all her friends. “Be safe.”

“Right. And Come’ere, Wildcat!” Scorpia grabbed Catra, pulling her into a hug despite the latter’s protests. Adora grinned at the sight.

“We’ll keep things going,” Netossa told them. “You forge the alliance with Earth.”

“Bye!” Entrapta waved at everyone as she walked up the ramp, where Hordak and SG-1 were waiting. Adora and the others followed her.

“That was a touching sendoff,” O’Neill told them at the top of the ramp. “I expected more speeches.”

“Speeches?” Adora blinked.

“You know, state affair, big speeches about the importance of this trip, a cheering crowd…” The man shrugged.

“It’s just a trip,” Catra remarked.

“It’s also a diplomatic expedition,” Daniel said.

“And the Alliance was here to see us off,” Catra pointed out.

“Right.” O’Neill nodded. “Everyone important, at least.”

They had reached the bridge, and Adora took her seat in the centre.

“Everyone, strap in!” Entrapta announced. “We’re ready for lift-off!”

As the holographic projections appeared, showing the state of the ship, the others sat down.

“All’s green!”

“System’s are good.”

Adora nodded. “Darla, take us up!”

The ship shook a little, then they rose, quickly clearing the palace walls. Then the view changed as Darla tilted, pointing her bow at the sky.

And then they were shooting towards space. Towards Earth.

“Your Divine Highness!”

And towards Third Fleet, which had been assembled in a close formation in orbit. Adora suppressed a sigh and smiled at the display showing their leader.

“Your Faithful stand ready to escort you on your holy mission!”

“Thank you, Priest,” she replied. “We’re happy to have you all with us. This is a very important mission.”

“We are ready to lay down our lives for you, Your Divine Highness!”

She winced. “Let’s hope it won’t come to that. We’re on a diplomatic mission.”

“Yes, Your Divine Highness!”

Catra snickered softly behind Adora. And O’Neill was mumbling something that Adora didn’t catch but which had both Daniel and Carter whisper to him. Or at him.

“Thank you,” she repeated herself. “Let’s proceed then.”

“Standard formation! Vanguard, cruise speed ahead!” Priest exclaimed. “Main force, form up around the Holy Vessel!”

Apparently, Darla had been upgraded in status. Adora really wanted to sigh. This was so embarrassing. And Catra found it incredibly amusing.

But they were moving now and would soon engage the hyperdrive.

“Now, let’s see if our calculations are correct!” Entrapta said. “We should be noticeably faster than before!”

“‘Should’?” O’Neill asked. “Haven’t you tested this?”

“Not on such a long trip, not yet,” Entrapta told him with a wide smile. “This will produce very useful data!”

It was clear that he didn’t share her enthusiasm, Adora noticed.

“Don’t worry,” she told him. “We are good at repairs in space.”

“Great.”

*****

Etheria System, July 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter watched the screens on the oversized bridge of Darla. According to the sensors, they were surrounded by Horde frigates. And since she could see some of the sleek ships just by looking out the windows on the bridge, she was inclined to believe the sensors.

“If the Navy ever sees the size of our escort, they’ll go green with envy,” the Colonel commented.

“The Navy?” Catra asked.

Sam hadn’t noticed her walking over to them. The woman could be very quiet, apparently. The claws on her feet must be retractable, so any sound they had made before on the floor had been by choice. Perhaps to make people underestimate her.

“You don’t have warships on Etheria?” The Colonel raised his eyebrows.

Catra snorted in return. “Of course we do - and you know it; you’ve met Mermista. So, there’s some rivalry between you and the Navy?”

“We’re Air Force,” the Colonel told her. “The Navy doesn’t like us.”

“I think it’s not quite so one-sided, Jack,” Daniel cut in. “At least according to, oh, everyone I met at the base. Except for the

Marines."

The Colonel grinned. "But the Navy started it. Anyway, they would be green with envy because you've got more ships as an escort than they have in total."

Catra, unexpectedly, frowned. "That'll make recruiting trained crew harder."

"They're trained on ships, not spaceships."

"But the principles are similar," Catra retorted.

"That is correct - in as much as Horde sailors are concerned. I set the training so they would require minimal training to crew spaceships as soon as we made contact with Horde Prime," Hordak said.

"Really?" The Colonel frowned in return. "That sounds a bit inefficient."

"The only major sea power amongst the Alliance is Salineas, and they became isolationist after the first Alliance fell apart. I considered the additional training worth the effort."

"And you lost the war," the Colonel said.

"Not because of my Navy."

"Well, we're Air Force. We're used to flying and crewing airplanes, so you'll find us more suited for crewing spaceships," the Colonel said.

"And Air Force pilots were the first astronauts," Sam pointed out.

"That, too. I guess we can recruit from NASA as well. That's our space agency."

"You've got space forces?" Catra asked.

“Not officially, no,” the Colonel admitted. “Nasa is a civilian agency.”

“And they don’t know about the Goa’uld, right?” Catra shook her head.

“That seems rather inefficient,” Hordak commented. Sam glanced at the alien - he wasn’t showing any expression. But Sam was used to Teal’c and was sure he enjoyed turning the Colonel’s words back at him.

The Colonels shrugged. “It worked well so far. We haven’t had much trouble with other services, no mass panic, not too many senators and other bigwigs meddling with operations, no international pressure…”

“And all built on a lie,” Catra replied.

“Technically, it’s an omission. A secret. You know, need to know and all that stuff.” The Colonel smiled, though it was a little forced. Sam could tell.

She cleared her throat. “So, I checked the route. We’ll be taking quite short trips through hyperspace.” According to what she had seen, Darla should be able to make much longer trips.

“Oh, that’s because we haven’t fully mapped out the route - our data isn’t as precise as it could be,” Entrapta said. “So we’ll be making frequent stops to check our data. Later, we’ll be able to shorten travel times. Also, this way, we can check that everyone kept up. If a frigate suffers a malfunction and drops out of hyperspace, she’ll be easier to find if we don’t have to backtrack all the way to Etheria.”

“Yeah.” The Colonel nodded. “Losing a spaceship is much more embarrassing than losing a plane.”

“Exactly!” Entrapta beamed at him. She turned to Hordak. “See?”

“Certain frigates wouldn’t be a loss at all,” Hordak said.

Catra scowled at him for that but didn't comment, Sam noticed.

"Everyone, strap in! We're engaging the hyperdrive in a minute," Adora announced.

"It's just for the very, very unlikely case that we've made a mistake modifying the hyperdrive," Entrapta said. "The data checks out, and, as I said, we've done shorter trips without issues, but sometimes, longer trips reveal a mistake in the setup."

Right. They were on a shakedown cruise. Sam pressed her lips together. It wasn't as if she'd never done anything like that. But, usually, it had been under pressure, with no time to carefully test anything. This wasn't the case here. Well, they were effectively at war, and the longer they waited, the higher the chance that Stargate Command would write them off, but…

"Three. Two. One. Hyperspace Window formed! Entering!"

And they were in hyperspace.

"Bubble's holding stable."

"No anomalies detected from the escorts."

Adora sighed audibly. "So, we're in hyperspace." She got up and stretched.

"And my scanners don't detect any signs of imminent system failures," Entrapta added.

Sam sighed herself. With relief. And a little apprehension.

They were on the way to Earth.

"Alea iacta est," Daniel mumbled, mirroring her thoughts. For good or ill, they were now committed. But then, they probably had been committed ever since they had met Adora and the others.

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Hyperspace Near Etheria, July 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

So, they were on their way to Earth. Catra sighed. It would take them about a month if Entrapta was correct - and the princess knew her business. About a month on the same ship as O'Neill and the others.

She looked around the bridge. It had changed since her first trip with it. For the better, in Catra's opinion. Originally, it had been She-Ra's ship. One single seat for her, no consideration for anyone else. Just She-Ra and the ship. That wasn't a good way to travel, in her opinion.

"Something wrong?" Adora asked in a low voice.

Catra snorted. "Just wondering about our passengers," she lied.

"Ah." Adora nodded with a slight frown. "You still don't trust them."

Well, duh, of course not. She shrugged.

"You threatened O'Neill."

"I warned him," Catra corrected her. "That's not the same."

"They're our guests," Adora said.

Catra shrugged again. If they hurt Adora, they could be their sworn allies for all she cared; she would make them pay.

"So far, everything looks good!" Entrapta announced.

"The ship's performing within expected parameters," Hordak added.

"And are those parameters good?" O'Neill asked. "Just checking!" he added with a grin.

"Why would we alter the ship's systems to decrease performance?" Hordak asked.

“That would only make sense if you’re trying to sabotage a ship,” Entrapta added. “And Darla is our ship.”

Adora’s actually, though Darla might have second thoughts about it, if she could talk, in Catra’s opinion - Entrapta had spent far longer with the ship.

“The ship’s speed exceeds the speed of known Goa’uld ships, Sir,” Carter said.

O’Neill nodded. “That’s good then. If you’re faster, you control the engagement.”

“Unless you’re on the defensive,” Catra pointed out. You couldn’t run if you had to hold the line. Or fortress.

“Yeah, yeah. But we’re in a spaceship. Even if we have to hold a planet, speed will help a lot. Right?” He looked at Teal’c.

“That is correct,” the big man replied. “Although by using the mass of your ships against important targets, you can force even faster enemies to engage you at a point and time of your choosing.”

This was starting to sound like a tactical course for cadets. Catra snorted and stretched, groaning softly as she bent and straightened her spine. “So, we’re in hyperspace and won’t drop out for a few hours at least.”

“Twelve, to be exact,” Etrapta cut in.

Catra nodded. “Twelve hours. So, what’s for dinner?”

“Rations,” Glimmer said.

Catra scoffed. “Yeah, right.” As if anyone would choose to eat rations, least of all a princess.

Glimmer chuckled. “I had the palace kitchen pack us a meal. We just need to reheat it.”

Catra perked up. That was better than what she had expected. "Don't tell Priest, or he'll try to have his cooks do the same for us."

Glimmer and Adora shuddered.

"I take it that clones aren't known for their cooking skills?" Daniel asked.

"In the Horde, efficiency was more important than frivolous comforts," Hordak said. "Rations provided everyone with what they needed."

O'Neill grimaced. "That doesn't sound like taste was a priority."

"It wasn't."

"Horde Prime had some great cooks," Catra said. She suppressed a shudder at the memories of her time with Horde Prime. Glimmer tensed, too, Catra noticed. "But they didn't survive the war." She frowned. Or had that been Horde Prime himself, taking over their bodies to cook his own meals? It seemed absurd, but Catra also could imagine Horde Prime declaring that only his cooking was good enough for him.

"Let's go then! I'm a little hungry after loading all our supplies," Adora announced, changing back into her normal form.

"Did they make tiny food, too?" Entrapta asked as they walked to the door. Or bulwark, since they were on a ship.

"I think they prepared tiny desserts," Glimmer said.

"Oh, good!"

"Ah… who's standing watch on the bridge?" O'Neill asked.

"Darla," Entrapta replied.

"The ship herself?" Daniel cocked his head and looked around.

“She knows best,” Entrapta told him. “And she can call us if we’re needed.”

O’Neill nodded, though he looked a little uncomfortable, Catra noted. Was that another Earth thing? Did he mistrust Darla? Or was he concerned about the fact that Darla had cameras all over the ship?

She kept an eye on the soldiers as they walked towards the mess, her ears twitching as she listened to their conversation. Ah. Something about Artificial Intelligences and computers. O’Neill didn’t trust bots.

Not a stupid attitude, of course - bots, no matter what Entrapta might say, weren’t people. Not even Light Hope. But Darla could be trusted - she hadn’t been messed with by the First Ones.

And not having to stand watch, at least not in hyperspace, made travelling easier. Catra wasn’t really looking forward to spending a night on the bridge instead of with Adora. Unless, of course, they could spend the night together on the bridge. Use the oversized She-Ra seat for something fun, for once.

But Adora wouldn’t want to risk anyone walking in on them, even though that only made it more fun. So, this would probably remain a fantasy.

Well, you couldn’t have everything you wanted. Catra had learned that the hard way.

*****

Hyperspace, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“All systems running as expected!”

Entrapta sounded so happy and excited, Jack O’Neill refrained from making a sarcastic comment. They were heading home to Earth. On a spaceship. With a fleet.

And waiting to finish the first leg of their trip - a 'standard navigational stop', as Entrapta put it. And yet...

"I didn't think that we'd travel to Earth on Love Boat," he muttered.

"Jack!" Daniel gasped next to him.

"What?" Jack nodded towards the others. Everyone was on the bridge, though Jack was sure that any Navy officer would have a fit if he saw them. Catra had placed herself in Adora's lap with one of the smuggest expressions Jack had seen lately. Glimmer and Bow were standing next to each other, talking in low voices, and looking at their expressions, Jack was sure that they weren't discussing politics or space travel. Unless they were literally in love with either. At least Hordak was checking the screens more than Entrapta. "Just look at them," he whispered.

"But…" Daniel shook his head. "That's obviously normal for them."

"Public displays of affection?" Jack grinned at his friend. "On duty?"

"Well, are they technically on duty?" Daniel asked.

"We finished breakfast twenty minutes ago," Jack pointed out.

"Yes, but…"

"We're ready to drop out of hyperspace," Entrapta announced.

Glimmer turned and walked towards Adora while Bow went to check the scenes on his side of the bridge.

And Catra slid out of Adora's lap.

"Now they're on duty," Daniel said. "See?"

Yeah, even General Hammond, for all that he was a rather laid-back Texan, would raise his eyebrows at that. Which would be

amusing, at least. Still, working alongside three couples? For a month? That was a little much. Jack very much didn't look at Carter.

"Dropping out in three...two...one!"

And they were back in 'normal space'.

Entrapta's hair tendrils flew over the consoles next to her. "Everything and everyone is where they should be. Deviations are within safety margins and tolerances."

The big screen lit up, and the clone commander appeared. "Your Divine Highness, we have arrived. All ships are accounted for! Command us!"

"Thank you, Priest." Adora nodded. "Start preparing for the next leg. As soon as we've finished our system check, we'll depart again."

Priest hit his chest and bowed. "As you command, Your Divine Highness. We shall prepare at once!"

The screen went blank again. Jack snorted. "I can see how that would grow old quickly."

Adora pouted at him.

He grinned. "You could tell him to use a title that's less of a mouthful."

"I tried," she said.

"Priest's 'unfailing devotion' fails when it clashes with his ideas on how to talk to a goddess," Catra said.

Which was rather worrying, though not unexpected, if Jack was honest. "So, he claims that he knows his dogma better than his goddess does? Wouldn't that qualify as heresy?"

“I’m not a goddess!” Adora snapped.

“I don’t think it would be considered heresy since Priest is the de facto head of their church,” Daniel said. “Although it’s hard to say since we don’t have gods that actually talk back when prayed to and might comment.”

“Except for the Goa’uld,” Jack said.

“False gods,” Teal’c stated.

“Well, in the past, something that went against established doctrine and custom of a religion often was called heresy, though since this faith is rather new, there probably is no established consensus about this yet.” Daniel pushed his glasses up. “Or Priest is defining it as we speak.”

“Don’t give him ideas!” Glimmer said.

“Even without writing scripture, his ideas will likely form the dogma of the faith,” Daniel pointed out. “As long as he is the uncontested leader of his, ah, flock.”

And if there was a schism, they would have to deal with two competing sects of religious fanatics with their own spaceships. A recipe for disaster if Jack had ever seen one. “Yeah, let’s hope that they don’t start splintering,” he said.

Adora sighed. “I just wish they’d stop treating me as a goddess.”

Catra snickered. “Just them, though, right?”

Adora blushed - Jack wasn’t going there - and Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“All systems check out!” Entrapta interrupted them. “Calculating the next course! Well, recalculating and adjusting for minor stellar drift. So far, we’re doing better than expected! The star charts we have are matching up well.”

"They should. We're talking stars. They shouldn't move erratically," Bow said.

"Well, Etheria was in another dimension for a thousand years," Entrapta retorted. "Its absence should have affected the other stars nearby. Not to any great extent, but enough to affect navigation."

Another dimension. Jack didn't want to even think about that. Scientists back home would have fits one that came out.

"Easily compensated for," Hordak commented.

"But we still need to verify the data through actual observation," Entrapta told him.

"Which we just did."

"Yes. And which we will keep doing!" Entrapta smiled. "This is exciting! We're making history - of sorts. It's not our first trip, after all, but we're much better prepared now."

"And we're not about to charge at Horde Prime's fleet," Catra said. "That's already an improvement."

Jack nodded. A nice, peaceful trip back to Earth would be perfect. No, it would be perfect if they found a Stargate on the way, so they could warn Earth.

*****

Hyperspace, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

The second trip through hyperspace went as well as the first. At least as far as Adora could tell. Entrapta and Hordak were tinkering with Darla or the shuttle or doing something else together that involved First Ones technology. Adora didn't know what exactly they were doing, and she wasn't sure she wanted to know. They were a lot closer than she had expected. Not that she

would admit that to Catra - her lover would be insufferably smug for having pointed it out before.

Her lover… Adora sighed as she twisted so she was lying on her side and looked at Catra. She had been curled up against Adora and now was groping for her body in her sleep. "You just want my body heat," Adora whispered with a smile as she wrapped her arms around her.

"I just want your body," Catra mumbled without opening her eyes as she snuggled into Adora's embrace.

"You're awake."

"Of course I am. You think I wouldn't notice you leaving just because I was asleep?" Catra whispered into Adora's chest.

Adora chuckled - Catra's breath was tickling her skin. And her tail wrapped itself around her leg. "Of course not."

"Good. 'Cause I'm not gonna let you leave."

"You will have to - well soon arrive at the next stop," Adora pointed out.

"We can sleep through it." Catra wrapped her arms around Adora and held on more tightly. "The others can watch Entrapta do her thing and then enter hyperspace again."

"And talk to Priest?"

"Bah! They can tell them you're doing your Divine Duty with me."

Adora snorted. "My Divine Duty?"

"Getting much-needed rest. R&R is crucial for a soldier, remember?"

"Ah. We haven't done too much resting today," Adora pointed out.

“That’s the recreation part,” Catra replied. “The best part of R&R.”

“Right.” The instructor in cadet school had told them so with a rare grin. Not that the Horde had been big on R&R in practice, though. Adora suppressed the urge to sigh. That was the past. They weren’t cadets any more. They weren’t Horde any more. Even if they might still be wearing their old uniforms. Or not wearing them right now. “But I can’t stay in bed. We’ve spent the whole trip in bed.” Well, much of it.

“I bet you we can.”

“I need to be on the bridge.” She had to. What if something happened? She was She-Ra. It was her duty.

Catra sighed this time. And not the happy, contented sigh she used after, well, recreation. “You’re a dummy.”

“But I’m your dummy,” Adora replied.

“And don’t you forget it.” Catra’s arms tightened around Adora, squeezing her for a moment before releasing her. “Let’s go be useless on the bridge then.” She rolled to the side, staring at the ceiling. “After dinner.”

“Right.” And after a shower.

*****

O’Neill looked a little grumpy, Adora noticed as they entered the mess. “Is something wrong with the food?” Adora asked. This meal hadn’t been prepared by the palace staff, after all, but by Bow.

“What? No, no. It’s peachy.”

“Peachy?” Adora asked.

“It’s fine. The food is good.” O’Neill speared a piece of meat with his fork and put it into his mouth.

“It’s excellent,” Daniel added with a smile.

“Much better than rations,” Catra commented as she filled her plate from the big pots.

“Indeed.”

“Where’s Sam?” Adora asked.

“In the engine room with Entrapta and Hordak,” O’Neill replied. “She took a sandwich.” He was frowning again.

Ah. Adora nodded. That was it. “Don’t worry. We’ll make them eat proper meals in the future.” Entrapta had been doing better until now. Hordak must be a bad influence on her. Or she was too excited about their trip, Adora added with a slightly guilty feeling. Hordak hadn’t done anything so far to make them suspect him. At least in her opinion.

And the food was good. She smiled at Bow. “It’s great!”

“Thank you!” He beamed at her.

Glimmer snorted. “I bet you would even find rations good, as famished as you must be.”

“Jealous?” Catra grinned between bites.

“Hardly!” Glimmer sniffed, then grinned. “It’s like a vacation, isn’t it? No court to bother us. All the free time we want while we travel. All the privacy we want” She smiled at Bow, who blushed a little.

Adora nodded. Her friend was right - this was nice. Nice so far. Darla wasn’t the palace, but they had their own rooms. And there were no guards or staff following them around and asking questions.

“Enjoy it while it lasts,” O’Neill said. He looked even grumpier now. “We’re still at war.”

“We know,” Catra told him. “It’s still nice. Nicer than our last war.”

Adora nodded. Definitely. She wasn’t fighting Catra this time. Etheria wasn’t about to be destroyed by some ancient superweapon. Her friends weren’t mind-controlled. It was much nicer than their last war.

So far.

“It’s a little new for us,” Daniel said. “We aren’t used to so much, ah, free time on a mission.”

“Right. You travel through gates,” Glimmer nodded. “No travel times.”

“Yes. We’re generally home for dinner,” O’Neill said.

Oh. Adora was so stupid - they were missing their home! “We’ll get you home soon,” she told him with a smile. “Promise!”

That didn’t seem to cheer him up as much as she had hoped. Not very much at all, actually.

*****

“And the hyperspace bubble is perfectly stable even with the changes to the generators here,” Entrapta explained.

Samantha Carter could see that. But she could also see something else. “It could be more efficient, though, if you tweaked the converter there.”

“That would remove redundancy,” Hordak objected. “Not something you want to do when it concerns hyperspace travel.”

“It wouldn’t remove redundancy - both this and the other converter there rely on the same systems,” Samantha pointed out. “The lessened strain would strengthen the whole system.”

“Oh, I see!” Entrapta piped up. “Yes, that would work. Probably. We need to test it.”

“Yes.” Hordak nodded in one of the most grudging ways that Sam had ever seen. She was sure that if Entrapta hadn’t agreed, he wouldn’t have agreed either. “We’ll have to make adjustments at the next stop.”

“Which is in… oh, five minutes! Time flies when you’re having fun!” Entrapta announced. “Let’s go to the bridge!” She turned and started for the door.

Sam followed her after a last glance at the machines in the room. Whatever else this trip might result in, she had learned a lot about advanced hyperspace drives. She might not yet be able to craft one herself, but she was close. And she should be able to duplicate a standard Goa’uld drive with the right parts.

But that could wait. First, they had to find a way back to Earth. Which meant a series of navigational stops to update their charts - because they had been out of touch and out of sync with the rest of the universe for a thousand years.

Sam still had trouble with the idea that an entire star system had been shifted to another dimension - a pocket dimension, even - for a thousand years. But the way everyone talked about it as something that had happened, the way people mentioned seeing stars for the first time in the sky… It had to be true. Something else to give nightmares to the people back on Earth who would be worried about magic.

Though Sam was also sure that more than a few people would be speculating about using something similar to save Earth in extremis. She hoped they wouldn’t find support - what she had heard about the Heart of Etheria from Entrapta gave her nightmares.

They reached the bridge, and Sam felt a brief pang of guilt and embarrassment when she noticed that everyone else was already

present. Arriving last was never a good thing for a subordinate.

“The drives are running fine!” Entrapta announced. “No trouble at all!”

“Good.” Adora nodded at them.

“Carter! Did you enjoy your sandwich?” The Colonel raised his eyebrows at her.

Sam suppressed the urge to frown - she knew what he really meant. “Yes, Sir,” she replied. “We tweaked the drives a bit.” She carefully didn’t smile at his slight twitch upon hearing that.

“Well, next time, take the time to eat with us like civilised people,” he told her. “Unless it’s an emergency, of course.”

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed, looking at Entrapta. “You need decent meals, not just snacks. Or tiny snacks.”

“We had rations,” Hordak said. “They covered our nutritional needs perfectly.”

Catra made a gagging noise, and everyone else from Etheria winced as well.

“They weren’t bad,” Sam said. “No as good as MREs, but edible.” She had tried some, after all.

“‘Not as good as MREs’? That’s practically poison, Carter!” the Colonel blurted out, shaking his head.

“Jack! People have different tastes and culinary traditions! You can’t just insult their meals like this!” Daniel protested.

“Of course he can - Horde rations are horrible,” Catra said. “I’ve eaten enough of them to know.”

Adora nodded. “Yes. There’s no comparison to actual food. And…”

"Exiting Hyperspace in one minute," the voice of the ship's computer interrupted her.

"Oh!" Entrapta turned to the screens and consoles. "Good girl, Darla!"

Sam watched the screens showing the power fluctuations in the hyperdrives. That was a critical phase of the trip - entering and leaving hyperspace. The phase that was most prone to failure, Hordak had claimed, which made sense.

But they made the transition without apparent trouble. All readings were within expected parameters.

"And the fleet made it out as well… getting a count… still complete!" Bow announced.

"The frigates were kept in top condition - anything that might fail was replaced," Hordak said. "And anyone," he added with a deep frown.

Priest appeared on screen a moment later, telling them what they already knew - Third Fleet had arrived safely - but taking longer with all the "Divine Highnesses" thrown in. He would be trouble; Sam was sure of that as well, even though she understood the reason they had taken him and his fleet along. Another reason that they needed to find a Stargate. If Priest got into a debate about religion with some of the more… fanatical faithful on Earth, the consequences could be catastrophic.

"Scanners running! Navigational update… We're at the projected coordinates, with a slight but expected deviation," Entrapta announced. "So, let's take the time to tweak the engines before we start the next leg of our trip!"

Sam nodded. "Yes."

"Tweaking our hyperdrives, Carter?" the Colonel asked.

"Minor adjustments to improve efficiency," she told him.

"Not so minor!" Entratpa beamed. "If this works, it'll make Darla even faster!"

"Ah. That's a good thing."

"Yes, Sir, it is," Sam replied before she could help it. She knew what she was doing.

"Scanning finished… Oh," Bow interrupted the Colonel's reply. "There's Naquadah on the planet in the nearby system. Processed Naquadah. According to our data, the system should be uninhabited."

Everyone looked at the screen. Naquadah on a planet? That usually meant advanced technology. And a Stargate.

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Outside System PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Anything in the system? Ships?"

"No," Catra replied. She didn't see any hostile contacts on the screen.

"We're outside their scanning range, right?" Adora asked.

"We're outside the range of the Goa'uld sensors that we know of," Bow told her.

That wasn't as reassuring as Catra liked. SG-1 might have claimed that the Goa'uld didn't advance their technology, but that was the sort of assumption that got your plans foiled at the worst moment, in Catra's experience. Granted, she had been fighting Adora and the princesses, not some age-old megalomaniac parasites, and SG-1 had a lot of experience with them, but still… She couldn't help worrying.

"And we didn't pick up any active scans," Entrapta said.

“Could they have picked up our scans?”

“They shouldn’t have. But…” Entrapta bit her lower lip. Not a good sign. “Third Fleet is big enough to show up on optical sensors - if they have some.”

Optical sensors? Oh, telescopes. The frigates’ colour scheme wouldn’t help, either.

“They would have to be looking at this exact location,” Hordak replied. “And we’re too far out for our arrival to be easily detected with hyperspace sensors, either.”

“That means travelling to the planet in the shuttle will take some time as well, though,” Catra said. And ‘not easily detected’ didn’t mean ‘undetectable’, either.

“If we want to travel to the planet in the first place,” Glimmer said.

Catra snorted at that. As if they wouldn’t check out the planet. O’Neill would probably walk there if he had to. And they had to know if there was a Goa’uld base so close to Etheria.

Glimmer smiled wryly. “It had to be said.” But she had that glint in her eyes - she was craving some action. The queen was rather bloodthirsty for a princess.

But that raised another question. “So, who’s going?” Catra asked.

“Me!”

“Us!”

“I want to see the new technology!”

“You need me on the ground - I can teleport us.”

“I can carry a Stargate if we need to.”

“We need to go and see if there’s a Stargate.”

“We’ve got the most experience with Goa’uld.”

“So, basically everyone wants to go,” Catra summed it up. But someone had to stay back and watch the ship. And Third Fleet.

Everyone looked at each other. Catra sighed. This would be ugly.

*****

“...and we’ll stay in contact. If there’s any trouble, you can come and relieve us,” Adora said.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “We - and the entire Third Fleet.”

“Don’t pout, Sparkles,” Catra told her. “Someone has to stay back, and you’re the Queen. You’re in command.”

“Yet no one is listening to me!” Glimmer looked like she was about to stomp her foot.

“Glimmer.” Bow put his hand on her shoulder.

She gripped it, sighing. “I know.”

Catra stretched. It sucked to be Queen. Not that she cared as long as she was with Adora.

“I still fail to see why I need to stay back,” Hordak complained.

“So in the case that we get discovered, people will not connect us to the Horde,” Entrapta replied. “Though we could disguise you, I guess…”

“We don’t have the time for that,” Catra lied.

“Be careful,” Glimmer said.

“Of course!” Adora nodded with a serious expression.

Catra suppressed a snicker. Adora and cautious? Yeah, right. Catra would have her hands full trying to keep her lover from risking her

life. “So, stay safe and don’t get bored,” she said.

“Right! Let’s go!” Entrapta hugged Hordak, then entered the shuttle. “Let’s see if our stealth system works!”

“Uh… it does work, right?” Daniel asked. “We’re about to fly towards a Goa’uld-controlled planet.”

“We’ve tested the system, and it should work,” Carter told him. “But this is the first time it’s used on an actual mission.”

“Nothing like field testing new gear on a recon mission,” O’Neill said with a snort.

“It’s very efficient!” Entrapta said, sticking her head out of the shuttle.

“As long as it works…” O’Neill muttered.

“It should, Sir. The calculations work out.”

“Sometimes, math doesn’t work in the field, Carter.”

“That’s not how it works, Jack,” Daniel said.

“You know what I mean.”

“Well, yes, but…”

“Let’s go!” Adora said. “The sooner we go, the sooner we’re back. For the Honour of Grayskull!”

Watching her lover grow into a huge princess never got old, in Catra’s opinion. But it was over quickly, and then Adora stepped into the shuttle. Catra waved at Glimmer, Bow and Hordak before following her. O’Neill might be worried, but Catra wasn’t. If Entrapta, Carter and Hordak were sure that the stealth system would work, then that was good enough for her. Entrapta might be a little too confident, and Carter was hard to read, but Hordak wouldn’t let Entrapta go if he didn’t trust their technology. And if it

didn’t work, well… They had She-Ra with them. And the shuttle was fast.

They were ready for whatever awaited them on the planet.

*****

The Ship

System PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill looked at the screen showing their destination. A round globe floating in space. Not as blue as Earth, but not a desert or jungle world. Just another nameless planet to explore. But this time, they weren't going through a Stargate - they were approaching it from space. In a stealth shuttle - at least if the stealth system, whatever it was, worked as planned. Carter at least seemed to think it would work, which was why Jack wasn't making much of a fuss about this. Entrapta was a bit too enthusiastic about taking untested equipment on dangerous missions, and Hordak… Jack refrained from scoffing. As if he'd trust a 'former' warlord. He had met enough warlords on Earth to know better.

Some of them he had met after flying into Indian country in a small craft and hoping that the enemy wouldn't spot you, far from any backup. Just like now. He snorted.

"Sir?"

"Just some memories, Carter," he said. "This is a much nicer ride than a Blackhawk."

"Ah." She nodded - she knew what he was talking about, of course. Not from personal experience. Well, not inside the Blackhawk. But she might have been ready to provide air support when called in.

"Blackhawk?" Daniel looked confused. "Ah!"

"Blackhawk?" Catra looked intrigued.

"A helicopter - an aircraft held aloft by a large propeller instead of wings or anti-gravity generators," Carter explained. "Or magic."

"Ah." The catwoman nodded. "Military transport?"

“Yes,” Jack said.

“And this reminds you of it? How big are they?” She gestured around the bridge.

“Not nearly as big,” Jack replied. “It’s just the feeling of trying to sneak into a place where you aren’t supposed to be and hoping no one spots you and starts shooting.”

“Ah!” She grinned. “Yes, that’s exciting.”

“And terrifying,” Daniel added.

“We’ve got She-Ra with us,” Catra said.

“That won’t help if the Goa’uld send a couple Death Gliders or Al’Kesh after us,” Jack retorted.

“A couple? She can handle those by herself - she once killed three frigates.” Catra glanced at Adora, who frowned at her.

“That probably was an attempt to gauge my power, not a serious attack,” Adora told her.

Catra rolled her eyes. “They tried to shoot us down.”

“But he only sent three frigates after us. He had many more of them, and the Horde never husbanded their forces like that. At least Hordak didn’t do that,” Adora retorted.

Right. Hordak was the kind of warlord who probably sent tank regiments to scout for the enemy. Then again, the US Army had done the same - or would have, if the Cold War had gone hot. But they were the Army. “That’s very interesting, but I’m more concerned about our situation, not what happened in the past,” Jack said. “So, is the stealth system working?” They were now inside the system.

“We haven’t been scanned - not with any scanner I would detect, at least,” Entrapta said. “Of course, passive detection remains a

possibility, but we've got camouflage against optical sensors, and our power systems and engines are shielded. And we haven't been shot at - not yet - so I think it's safe to say our systems are working." She blinked. "Or they aren't working, but no one's looking for us. Which is also good. I think. Though we wouldn't know if the system's working, in that case."

"Or we're flying into a trap," Jack pointed out.

"Then we turn the trap on the enemy," Catra said. "They won't expect us. If they are waiting for us, they'll expect First Ones."

"Who had better technology than we have," Jack said.

"Not quite!" Entrapta shook her head, her animated hair not moving from the console. It looked very weird, as if someone had glued the tips of her hair to the keys and switches. "We've upgraded the systems to be on par or better than Horde technology - Horde Prime's tech, I mean. And his technology is at least as good as the First Ones was."

Right. "I'd still prefer not to enter a trap," Jack said. Overconfidence killed.

"If things go wrong, we just have to hold out long enough for Third Fleet to arrive," Catra said. "We should be able to manage that."

Adora nodded.

"Magic should give us an advantage," Carter added.

Magic. "I know," Jack said. He wasn't happy about it, though. He didn't know what exactly magic could do. That made planning, and, more importantly, adapting plans under fire, difficult. "Let's hope the people on the planet are friendly."

"The presence of Naquadah usually indicates Goa'uld," Teal'c said. "They do not leave their slaves with such technology."

"I know," Jack said. "Unless it's a Stargate." He hoped it was a Stargate.

"We'll know soon enough!" Entrapta's hair moved over the consoles as she typed. "A little bit longer, and we're in range for a deep scan." She tilted her head. "We'll be using magic, so they shouldn't detect that."

Magic again. But there was no helping it. "Good," Jack said.

A few minutes later, Entrapta announced: "OK, stop! We're close enough! Scanning now!"

That meant they were sitting still in space. Jack clenched his teeth. He hated being unable to affect the situation. At least on the ground, he could do something if they were attacked.

"Oh! I found the concentration of Naquadah. It's all in one place!" Entrapta announced. "It's… on the screen!"

Jack stared. He knew that thing.

"An Al'Kesh," Teal'c said.

"It looks like it crashed," Carter added.

"Right." Jack nodded. Not a Stargate, then. But not a Goa'uld base, either. "Any signs of life around it?"

"Yes, but… it's kinda hard to sort out animals and people," Entrapta said.

"Structures?" Daniel asked.

"Some, but they seem kinda damaged."

The screen changed, showing ruins.

"Goa'uld style," Daniel stated the obvious.

*****

“Goa’uld style?” Adora asked.

“Well Egyptian style, to be precise,” Daniel went on. “But outside Earth, only the Goa’uld beholden to Ra used this style.

So, that was how the enemy houses looked. It wasn’t very impressive. Drab stone houses, flat roofs, single floor…

“Looks pathetic,” Catra said out loud what Adora wasn’t quite thinking.

“Well, those are obviously quarters for their slaves,” Daniel explained. “No Goa’uld would be living in such, ah, squalor.”

“They would be so shamed, they could never show their face at the courts of their betters again, should anyone know of this,” Teal’c added.

“Yeah. But if given a choice between death and this?” O’Neill shook his head. “They’ll live like this. And they’ll jump you when you least expect it.”

“Well, we’ve got Melog. They’ll sniff them out,” Catra said, patting their friend on the flank. “No surprises there.”

“And I think if there were Goa’uld on the planet, they would have had their slaves construct a palace,” Daniel added.

“They might not have had the means,” Entrapta said.

“If there’s enough stone and clay to construct slave quarters, there’s enough stone and clay to construct a palace,” O’Neill said. “That’s how they think. They would sacrifice hundreds of slaves to get a palace.”

“But… That makes no sense!” Entrapta protested, shaking her head. “That’s… they would hurt themselves like that! Everyone suffers if you do that! Palaces don’t get you anything you can use to improve your position!”

“That’s the Goa’uld for you,” O’Neill told her. “Long-term planning isn’t their strength.”

“That’s not true,” Daniel protested. “They do make long-term plans - and the loss of slaves is often a welcome side-effect for them. If their slaves would grow too experienced, too skilled or too numerous, they might become a threat.”

“Even in the case of being shipwrecked?” Catra pointed at the screen.

“Yes,” Teal’c said. “Without a way off the planet, they would be unable to retreat or call reinforcements. Keeping their slaves cowed and from becoming a threat would be their priority.”

They sounded horrible but also short-sighted to Adora. “And why did the ship crash?”

Entrapta pushed a few buttons, and the screen’s image zoomed in on the shipwreck. “The scan’s results are not completely clear, but this here…” One of the strands of her hair pointed at a scorch mark on the hull. “...looks like weapon damage.”

“Unrepaired weapon damage,” Sam added.

“Well, the whole ship’s kind of unrepaired,” O’Neill commented.

“It means that the damage was likely taken shortly before the ship crashed or was the cause of the crash,” she explained. “Otherwise, they might have repaired part of the damage at least.”

“I knew that,” O’Neill claimed. “So, any active power plants or anything down there?”

“Just the Naquadah in the ship,” Entrapta replied. “Nothing active. They could have shielded their installations, of course - the planet’s crust contains several heavy elements that are hard to scan through.”

“If they are lying in ambush, they probably are waiting until we get to the ship,” O’Neill pointed out.

“That’s obvious,” Catra replied. “But how long would they have waited to ambush a ship?”

That was a good point. Too much caution was as bad as too little, as Shadow Weaver used to… Adora clenched her teeth. She wasn’t going there. “Let’s go down,” she said.

“Alright! Shields are up, and scanners are running!” Entrapta announced. “Stealth system is still running. We’re on final approach to the planet now!”

Adora took a deep breath. For better or worse, they were now committed. If there was an ambush ahead, it would be her fault. No one else’s. And she would…

An elbow in her rib interrupted her thoughts. “Don’t brood,” Catra hissed.

“I’m not brooding!” Adora whispered back.

“You were,” her lover insisted. “I know you.”

Being aware of your responsibilities wasn’t brooding!

“We’re approaching the orbit of the planet’s moon,” Entrapta said. “Still no sign of any active scan.”

That was good. “Plot a course so we are descending on the opposite side of the planet,” Adora told her friend. “We can fly to the shipwreck through the atmosphere.” That should keep them at least a little safer.

“Good idea,” Catra agreed.

O’Neill nodded as well.

Adora took a deep breath as the planet grew larger on their screens - now she could see it through the bridge's windows. It didn't seem really different from Etheria. A little less water on the surface, according to Entrapta's data. "Any sign of villages?" she asked. "Fields?"

"Nothing," Entrapta replied. "If they have gone into hiding, they have done a very thorough job."

Which would mean that any ambush would be very dangerous. Adora bit her lower lip and ignored Catra's sigh. She couldn't help worrying. Not when her friends were in danger. Possible danger.

But they reached the planet's orbit without getting attacked and quickly entered the planet's atmosphere. Adora stared at the sight of air glowing brightly outside, on the shuttle's shield.

"That's not going to be hidden easily," O'Neill commented.

"We're still working on that," Entrapta said.

"A shielding system that compensates for this is complicated," Sam said.

"I'm not criticising you, Carter," O'Neill told her.

"We've put the planet between us and the ship, but if they have sensors spread over the surface, they might notice us," Entrapta explained. "Though they might mistake us for a meteor."

"If we're lucky," O'Neill said.

"Yes."

But they were now flying over forests and meadows or what you called the places with grass and bushes without trees.

Towards the wrecked Goa'uld ship.

"If there's an ambush, they need to spring it now," Catra said. "Or they want to catch us on the ground." Adora glared at her, and she grinned in return. "Just saying."

*****

PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

An ambush on the ground was a possibility - the shuttle and the group would be most vulnerable while disembarking. Samantha Carter knew that. On the other hand, Catra was correct: The odds of that happening were low. People didn't go into hiding and waited for years, possibly decades or centuries - the ruins looked old - for someone to arrive.

Unless there was another reason why they wanted to hide. If they were hiding from an enemy… "They might have gone into hiding to avoid catching Horde Prime's attention," Sam said.

Catra and Adora turned to stare at her. "Right," Adora said. "That would be a reason to hide every sign of inhabitation."

"But if they are hiding from the Horde," Catra objected, "then they won't attack us and risk discovery."

"We don't look like the Horde," the Colonel said.

"We've got a Horde fleet waiting outside the system," Catra retorted.

"Which is hidden from their scanners." The Colonel shook his head. "But we're here already. Leaving would be suspicious. Might as well find out what happened here," he added with a grin.

Catra frowned at him but nodded. "Let's go."

"Put us down… behind that hill there. It should shield us in case they got the weapons of the ship working," Adora said.

“Even if the staff cannons were working,” Sam pointed out, “they are mounted in ventral turrets - they couldn’t fire at us from that angle.”

“They can’t fire up?” Catra asked, blinking.

“They are bombers,” Teal’c said. “Death Gliders are supposed to cover them during attack runs.”

“‘Supposed to’.” Catra shook her head. “Didn’t seem to have worked for this one.”

“It doesn’t seem to be a very effective design,” Entrapta commented.

“Oh, they’re effective enough at bombing planets,” the Colonel told them.

“But still!” Entrapta protested. “A more versatile design shouldn’t be too hard.”

“It’s also a matter of cost,” Sam told her. “An Al’Kesh has one purpose: delivering bombs and fire support for attacks against ground targets - or against capital ships. They aren’t built to dogfight.”

“But…”

“We can discuss spaceship designs and tactics later. Let’s go and take a look at the wreck. And find out if anyone is waiting to ambush us,” Catra said.

“Don’t forget the ruins,” Daniel said. “We can learn a lot from the remains of such settlements!”

“Ship first, then ruins,” the Colonel told him. “Stone huts generally aren’t as dangerous as spaceships.”

“But Jack…”

“Ship first. It’s the obvious trap. The metal and Naquadah would help hide an ambusher.”

“Right.” Daniel looked mulish but nodded.

Good.

“Let’s land then,” Adora said.

“Alright!” Entrapta smiled, and the ship started descending, quickly setting down behind the hill.

Adora was already moving to the rear, followed by Catra - who stopped to grab a short club-like device from the shuttle’s weapons locker. A shock-rod - Sam had examined them before. “In case we want to take prisoners,” Catra said.

“Catra!” Adora snapped.

“What? If we get attacked, we need prisoners to find out who they are. If you knock everyone out, we have to wait until they wake up.” Catra grinned.

Adora frowned at her. “Fine!”

Sam exchanged a glance with the Colonel. He shared her expression - their allies did seem to be more than a little overconfident.

Then again, they had seen how strong Adora was. Perhaps the Etherians had every reason to be so confident.

The air outside was fresh and mild. Temperate climate - warm but not hot.

“No signs of agriculture,” Entrapta commented. “No fields.”

“They could be hunter-gatherers,” Daniel said. “Although this would’ve been a regression even for slaves of a Goa’uld lord. They

couldn’t maintain a higher population density with such methods. You need organised agriculture for that.”

“Come on,” Catra said, already halfway up the hill.

“Catra!”

“I’m just going to take a look!”

Sam followed them up the slope. At the crest, she found Catra and Adora both prone in the grass, looking at the ship and the ruins below them through binoculars.

“Is that a Horde design?” she asked.

“The binocs? Yes. I like them better than the telescopes that Bright Moon and Salineas use,” Catra said. “More compact.”

“I’m used to them,” Adora added.

“Ah.” Sam pulled out her own binoculars and took a look at the ship. Definitely an Al’Kesh. And it didn’t look modified. Standard engine housing. The cockpit looked destroyed - that would have caused the crash.

“No markings,” the Colonel commented.

“Whoever piloted it did not want to be recognised,” Teal’c said.

“That would fit a recon mission in potentially hostile territory,” the Colonel agreed. “If they were afraid of pissing off Horde Prime…”

“Or the First Ones,” Catra added. “The ship looks old - it’s half-buried in the ground. Could be old enough so the First Ones were still around when it crashed. Can you detect anyone, Entrapta?”

“No life signs inside the ship. Or in the ruins. Well, no human-sized ones. Plenty of smaller ones.”

“Goa’uld larvae?” Adora asked.

"Not in the ruins - no Naquadah there. I can't exclude the possibility of them being in the ship, though."

"If you see a weird pot, don't smash it," the Colonel said. "It could contain a Goa'uld."

"Melog?" Adora looked down at the alien.

Melog growled something.

Catra nodded. "Melog doesn't sense any Goa'uld, either. But there could be some in the ship."

"Let's find out," the Colonel said. "But carefully."

*****

Crashed Al-Kesh, PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

As she approached the crashed ship, Catra couldn't see any trap or people waiting in ambush - and she had experience with both; the Alliance usually had had to resort to ambushes and traps to face the Horde troops. She didn't have experience with Goa'uld, though. None of them except for SG-1 had any experience. And Melog. Even Horde Prime's data - what they had managed to recover - barely covered the essentials about the parasites. Some data about their ships. Some basic tactics. Nothing more.

But they knew Goa'uld didn't have magic, and that severely limited their options.

"I'll go in first," Adora said as they reached the hole in the back of the ship.

"I've got the better eyes and ears," Catra retorted. Melog growled in agreement.

"But I'm tougher." Adora took a step forward.

“Did anyone forget to tell me that this is a competition?” O’Neill commented from behind them.

Catra frowned at the man. This wasn’t about him. This was about Adora trying to protect everyone at the cost of her own life.

Melog growled again. *Enter.*

“Melog says to enter,” Catra told the others.

“And who put the cat in command?” O’Neill asked.

Catra bared her fangs at him in a wide grin.

“The other cat.”

But Adora used the distraction to step forward and climb into the ship. Catra cursed and rushed after her, jumping through the hole in the hull.

She landed on all fours behind Adora in a dark corridor. Keeping her balance on the tilted floor was easy for her - her claws could dig into the metal floor. She tested her claws on the walls as well - it was always good to know if you could cut your way through the wall or ceiling. Which she could. “I expected more gold,” she whispered.

“That would have given an enemy clues about the ship’s origin.” Teal’c was climbing in behind them. And Melog pushed past him, landing on the floor and sniffing.

“Which way to the bridge?” Adora asked.

“This way.” Teal’c pointed with his staff.

The interior didn’t look like someone had been using it for a long time - there was a lot of dirt and debris on the floor near the hole, and Catra could see - and smell - signs of animals having used the ship as a lair. Ew. “Looks abandoned,” she whispered as they walked past a room full of broken crystals.

“Oh! That must have been a power station!” Entrapta exclaimed. “Look at the fittings here!”

“Later!” Catra told her as she grabbed Entrapta’s collar before the princess could climb into the room. “We need to check the bridge. No wandering off.”

“But!”

“Don’t make me have Adora carry you.”

Entrapta pouted but didn’t try to check out the next broken console they passed.

“There are no bodies,” Adora commented.

“They would have been taken out and buried by the survivors,” Teal’c said.

“We didn’t see any graves in the ruins,” O’Neill retorted.

“They might have buried the dead at a different place,” Daniel explained. “Many cultures separate the dead from the living.”

“Like a city of the dead?” O’Neill asked.

“Yes.”

“Well, that - or the animals in here ate them,” Catra said.

“We’d still find bones and inedible remains,” Carter replied. “And the ruins outside indicate that people explored the ship after crashing.”

“Unless the ruins predate the ship’s crash,” Daniel said. “I mean, if the village was in ruins before the ship arrived here.”

“The doors to the bridge are closed,” Teal’c reported. “Sealed.”

“Let me at it!” Adora summoned her sword and pushed it through the door with a soft grunt under her breath. Then she twisted the

sword and leveraged the door open.

Catra half-expected to find bodies behind the door, but the bridge was empty as well. And damaged. She pushed past Adora and moved to the chair closest to the door. It had a big hole inside the backrest. And the chair was discoloured slightly.

She bent over and sniffed.

“Can you smell blood after all this time?” Adora asked.

“No,” Catra told her with a grin. Her friend really should know her better than that. “But if it’s not so old, I would have.”

“Ah.”

“They suffered damage before crashing,” Teal’c said. “And someone removed the corpses and then sealed the door.”

“Communications are shot,” Carter added.

“What about the computers?” O’Neill asked.

“I’m trying to access them,” she replied. “If we can restore power and get the log or at least the navigational data…”

“It’s an intriguing system!” Entrapta added, beaming at them.

“Keep at it,” O’Neill said before looking around. “So, I’d say never split the party, but we should search the whole ship as well.”

“Oh, if you do, check out the Naquadah concentration on the other side,” Entrapta said.

“The Naquadah concentration?” O’Neill asked.

“The one we detected with my scanner,” Enptrata told him. “It should be…” She scrunched her nose. “About... this way!” her hair pointed at the back of the ship.

“The cargo hold,” Teal’c said after cocking his head to the side.

That sounded interesting. Catra grinned. “Let’s go, then!”

“Carefully,” O’Neill said.

Catra rolled her eyes. She hadn’t heard anything in the ship except for their own footsteps. And Melog hadn’t sensed anything either.

Teal’c took the lead again, and they made their way to the cargo hold - through a section that had been torn up by weapon fire: the hull breach was small, but both the corridor and the crew quarters behind it had been torn up, so they had to climb through the wreckage.

But they reached the cargo hold, Adora got to show off She-Ra’s strength again, forcing the doors open, and they found…

“A Stargate?”

*****

“A Stargate!” Jack O’Neill grinned. That was the best find they could’ve hoped for - they could go back to Earth now.

“The ship must have been moving a Stargate,” Teal’c stated the obvious.

“And where’s the dialer?” Catra asked.

“Good question.” Jack looked around. They wouldn’t ship just the ring. Not the Goa’uld. So… He stared at the broken crates in the corner. Next to another hull breach. “No.”

“D.H.D.s are quite tough,” Daniel said. “It shouldn’t easily break…”

That was true. Those things were built to last millennia. In order to break one, you practically had to shoot… He blinked as he approached the crates. The crates looked as if they had absorbed whatever blast had broken through the hull. “Damn!”

Jack quickly climbed the last few yards over broken ground and torn plates to the crates.

Not as quickly as Catra, though, who easily passed him with a few leaps, leaving gouges in the metal where she held on with her claws. Jack really didn't want to know what those claws would do to a human body - they would go straight through the heaviest body armour Stargate Command had. Hell, they would probably go through an APC's armour!

Catra reached the top of the crates and leaned over like a gymnast, peering inside upside-down, her tail twitching above her. "Oh."

"What?" Jack snapped as he pulled up next to her, carefully looking for footholds.

"You're not gonna like it."

"What?" he repeated himself as he peered over the edge and into the crate himself. Oh. "For crying out loud!"

The D.H.D. had absorbed the brunt of the blast - all that was left was the pedestal. The rest was a twisted mess of molten and blasted metal and crystal.

"They broke it!"

*****

"...and so, according to the partial data we recovered from the computer systems - quite interesting encryption, actually, very interesting ideas but they were implemented a little haphazardly, I think, since we were able to bypass half the protections by directly accessing the memory crystals - the ship was part of an effort to remove Stargates from planets in the sector. No data about who gave the orders, though."

Jack O'Neill forced himself not to scowl. It wasn't Entrapta's fault that the Goa'uld and whoever had been fighting them had

managed to wreck SG-1's ticket home. They had a Stargate, after all, which was a prize itself. Once they could get a computer hooked up to it and a powerplant. A Stargate that wasn't central to a planet's survival and could be taken home without dooming people.

Provided Earth could get it - Etheria might want it as well. But they could sort this out later.

"They were removing Stargates from the sector?" Adora asked.

"Presumably to deny them to others," Carter replied. "The dates line up with what we know as the height of the war between the First Ones and Horde Prime."

"Ah."

"They didn't want Horde Prime to get access to the Stargate," Catra said. "I bet the First Ones evacuated or destroyed Stargates as well."

"Probably, but we lack any data to tell for sure," Entrapta said.

"Scorched earth," Jack said. That would fit a force willing to sacrifice an entire planet to win a war.

"They attacked Earth?" Entrapta asked with wide eyes.

"No, scorched earth is a tactic used in wars on Earth. It consisted of removing or destroying everything the enemy could use while withdrawing in front of their advance. The goal was to deprive the enemy of resources and strain or collapse their supply system. It was quite effective against enemies who had been planning to live off the land," Daniel explained.

"Ah." Catra nodded. "That wouldn't have worked well on Etheria. We - the Horde - never used much of the resources of the Alliance lands for the troops themselves, not officially at least. And the Horde lands were pretty safe for most of the war."

“Whatever,” Jack said. “So, the snakes were taking Stargates and moving them… where, exactly?” If they could find the planet they had been moving the Stargates to, they could find a D.H.D.

Carter winced, and Jack knew he wouldn’t like her answer before she opened her mouth. “We only have coordinates in space - they were apparently meant to deliver the Stargates to a mothership.”

Probably a Ha’tak. Of course the snakes wouldn’t make it easy for them.

“They must have done this to avoid being identified, should they be caught,” Teal’c said. “No markings, no navigational data betraying their origins - that is not standard procedure for Goa’uld forces.”

“And probably carried suicide pills,” Jack muttered. “So, it could have been on the orders of anyone, even Ra since he was still alive back then.”

“It was probably not Ra,” Teal’c said. “As the ruler of the System Lords, he would likely have been held accountable for their actions anyway.”

“Unless he wanted to be able to blame someone else as a sacrifice,” Catra pointed out.

“He could have done so anyway,” Teal’c retorted.

“But Horde Prime - or the First Ones - might not have cared anyway,” Adora pointed out.

“Or it might have been the Tok’ra,” Daniel added. “We don’t know how they operate.”

“Right. I still think it’s more likely that this was done by a System Lord trying something underhanded,” Jack said. And the snake who had done this was probably still alive. And had a few spare Stargates. You could do a lot with that. And they didn’t know how

many the Goa'uld behind this had collected. "Let's hope we find more information in the ruins."

"And the graveyard that should be around," Daniel added.

"Yes, Daniel. We will be looking for tombs as well. I'll even get you a whip," Jack told him.

"A whip?" Catra asked, raising her eyebrows.

"He's referring to a movie trilogy from Earth, Indiana Jones," Daniel explained with a pout. "The main character is an archaeologist who occasionally uses a whip to fight his enemies."

Jack grinned. "And he crawls around in tombs." And dealt with magic shit. Perhaps the comparison is a little too on the nose, he thought.

*****

Ruins near crashed Al-Kesh, PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

The buildings really weren't much to look at, Adora had to agree with Catra. They were basically stone huts - or had been stone huts before turning into, well, ruins. Small ones, with flat roofs, many of them collapsed, and few windows next to gaping doors. About half a dozen, in total.

"Even for a village, that's not much," she said.

"Mhh." Catra made an agreeing noise as she looked around. "Kinda creepy, though."

"Yes." Like that ghost village of the First Ones Adora had found on Etheria. Well, they hadn't been real ghosts, but it still had been creepy.

"Daniel?" O'Neill asked.

Adora turned to look at Daniel, who was kneeling in the doorway of one hut.

“No remains of the curtain that served as a door, except for the holes holding it in place,” Daniel replied. “This village has been deserted for a long time.”

“What’s a long time in years?”

“Without a carbon analysis, I can’t be more precise,” Daniel replied with a slight pout. “I don’t know the local climate to even try to date anything according to the erosion and build-up of sand. Or what kind of animals or microorganisms might attack the fabric.”

“Well, wood survived,” O’Neill commented. “And there are two beds in here - or their remains. Wouldn’t want to try and sleep on this.”

Catra snorted and peered inside. “I’ve slept on worse during training.”

“Well, me too, but that doesn’t mean I want to sleep on that.”

“Better than no sleep at all or on the bare ground,” Catra replied.

“True.” O’Neill nodded. “And it even got a roof. Half of one.”

“Better than nothing.” Catra snorted. “Could house a platoon in this village easily. No place to hide transports, though. Much less tanks.”

Adora frowned. As much as she liked Catra warming up to their guests and allies, she didn’t like it when Catra talked about her time in the Horde like that. She wasn’t in the Horde any more. The Horde wasn’t any more. They were no longer enemies.

She saw Daniel use a knife to scratch the wall next to the door and walked over to him. “What did you find?”

The man cocked his head, taking a closer look. “It’s a really primitive construction. Basically, mud bricks. Not fired, just dried.” He rose. “I think this was built by survivors of the crash. If a System Lord had ordered a village built here, it would have used better materials.”

“They could’ve been runaways,” O’Neill pointed out.

“Runaways from what? There’s no other settlement on the planet,” Daniel retorted. “No, I think this was built by survivors from the crash.”

Teal’c stepped inside the hut and picked up what looked like the remains of a chair. He blew at it, revealing a pattern on the wood. “A traditional Jaffa carving,” he explained.

“Jaffa? That would fit the crew of the Al’Kesh,” O’Neill said, nodding. “And the whole spartan interior. Humans would probably have looted the ship for better furniture.”

“Why wouldn’t Jaffa have done that?” Adora asked.

“If they had removed parts of the ship’s furniture, it would have meant that repairs would have taken longer, should relief forces have arrived,” Teal’c said. “That would have gone against the standing orders of most System Lords. Few Jaffa would have disobeyed such an order. Certainly not those trusted with what seems to have been a secret mission. ”

Adora blinked. “You mean they lived…” She looked around. “They could’ve lived more comfortably if they had disobeyed orders? Taking chairs back would have cost, what, half an hour?”

Teal’c nodded.

“Now that reminds me of the Horde,” Catra said. “Just that we did disobey such stupid orders whenever we could get away with it.” She looked at the shipwreck. “We probably would’ve stripped the thing bare and blamed the Alliance if anyone asked.”

“Personal comfort is not a priority for a Jaffa,” Teal’c said.

“And, apparently, neither is thinking for yourself,” Catra mumbled.

Adora winced as she nodded in agreement.

“Well, let’s check the other buildings,” Catra said. “Let’s see what we find.”

The next houses contained mostly the same - broken wood, sand and dust. “Where are the tools?” Adora asked. “How did they eat?”

“Their personal mess kits, probably,” Teal’c replied.

“And where are those?” Adora asked.

“And the weapons,” O’Neill added. “There are bound to be some staff weapons and zat’nik’tels around. There were none inside the ship.”

So, the Jaffa took their weapons outside. Well, that made sense.

“They might’ve built an armoury,” Catra speculated.

“Unlikely,” Teal’c said. “A Jaffa is expected to carry and care for their weapons on such missions.”

“Well, they certainly aren’t expected to get drunk, then,” Catra mumbled.

Adora was about to laugh as she ducked inside the next hut. But the sight of a corpse - well, a skeleton - stopped her short. “I found one of the crew,” she said.

Catra was at the window in a second. “Oh… died in bed?” She cocked her head.

“It looks like they died…” Adora trailed off as she took a few steps closer and examined the ribcage. Which had several ribs missing. “Violently.”

Catra slid through the window and joined her. She placed her hand at the ribcage's remains, then unsheathed her claws and moved the hand alongside the broken, missing ribs, matching the likely path that had cut deep into the man's side. "Whatever it was, it was bigger than my hand."

"And he was armed," Adora added, pointing at a small 'zat gun' which had fallen through the bed frame. There was what looked like a plate and a fork in a coner, too.

"Right."

*****

"So, what happened?" the Colonel asked. "Chestbuster accident?"

Samantha Carter rolled her eyes before standing up and turning to face him. She knew he wasn't serious, but sometimes, his jokes were… not really appropriate. Or funny. "No, Sir," she replied, standing straighter - that was a good way to rebuke him without words, she had found - "the wounds were, as far as I can tell, and Catra agrees, caused by either a multi-bladed weapon or a set of claws."

"He was attacked in bed?" The Colonel raised his eyebrows.

"The wound wouldn't have been immediately fatal," Teal'c said. "A Jaffa wouldn't have lain there and died without taking their attacker with them. So, I concur that he was attacked somewhere else, killed whoever attacked him, and then returned to base before dying from his wounds."

"Or her," Adora pointed out.

"Most Jaffa on such missions are male," Teal'c replied, "but there is a possibility that this warrior was female, yes." He inclined his head.

"So…" The Colonel shook his head. "What are the odds that whatever or whoever took out a heavily armed Jaffa is still

around?" The way he said it made it clear that he thought the question was rhetorical.

"Uh…" Adora frowned. "I guess that depends on how long ago this happened. And how old whoever did this can grow."

Well, the Etherians hadn't known the Colonel as long as Sam had.

"Could it have been another survivor?" Catra asked.

"Jaffa generally live for up to a hundred and fifty years - until we cannot take another symbiote and die," Teal'c said. "Since the survivor of the Al'Kesh's crew had no means to receive another symbiote, they could not have lived for longer than a few years."

Adora gasped, and Catra winced. "They… they knew they would die like this?" Adora asked.

"Yes." Teal'c nodded again.

"So… no Jaffa would have lived so long," Catra said.

"And we don't know any other species who would have lived for close to a thousand years," Daniel added. "With the exception of the Goa'uld, and they are a special case."

"We don't know how long the Nox live," Sam reminded the others.

The Colonel scoffed. "I doubt they would have attacked a Jaffa." He pressed his lips together. "But we know that every Jaffa had a symbiote. So, there were at least a dozen baby Goa'uld on this planet at one time."

Sam drew a short breath as she clenched her teeth. "And Goa'uld can take animals as hosts."

"And we detected life signs in the area when we scanned it from orbit," Entrapta piped up with a smile.

“Right. We could be surrounded by tigers possessed by snakes,” the Colonel commented. “Don’t let Hollywood hear about this.”

“Hollywood?” Adora asked.

“The people who make their movies,” Catra told her.

“Ah.”

Daniel opened his mouth, no doubt about to correct them, but the Colonel clapped his hands together. “Right, people! We might be facing possessed animals with claws that make a Kodiak jealous. Stay sharp! No one is going off alone anywhere.”

Sam nodded. If those were just animals, she wouldn’t be very worried. But Goa’uld-possessed animals? They wouldn’t kill the group - they would want hosts. She closed her eyes for a moment, shuddering at the sudden memories of her brief period of being a host. She’d rather be eaten alive by a bear than suffer that again.

“Does that mean that we won’t look for their graveyard?” Daniel asked.

“No. We need to know what happened here,” the Colonel said. Adora nodded in agreement.

Both Adora and Catra didn’t look too concerned, Sam noticed. Entrapta didn’t look concerned at all, but, well… the princess had different views of what was concerning.

“So… where could the city of the dead be?” the Colonel asked, standing at the window of the hut and peering outside.

Teal’c was already covering the door.

“Well, traditionally, it would be at quite a distance. But since they were stranded here and had limited resources, I don’t think it would be too far away. If they were concerned about grave robbers, perhaps the people who shot them down, they would

have been looking for sites that hid the graves," Daniel explained. "Although Jaffa burial rites might be different from Egyptian ones."

"For Jaffa following the Goa'uld, they usually follow the dictates of their false gods," Teal'c said.

"Then they would likely follow Egyptian traditions. Which, of course, varied over time."

"We didn't detect other weapons," Entrapta said. "So, they were either completely depleted or placed in locations where they would be shielded from scans. Or both." She pushed a button on her tool. "So… the closest such location would be the hill to the north. Well, the direction set as north here - we picked the pole kind of arbitrarily. But as long as everyone agrees that it's north, it's OK, I think."

"Yeah. How far is that?"

"About five of your miles!"

Not a short trip, but not a long hike, either. But walking, with potentially a dozen intelligent predators in the area? Through unknown terrain? And carrying whatever they might find back? "Sir, I suggest that we take the shuttle there," Sam said.

"Right. We're Air Force, not Army," the Colonel said. "We can…" he trailed off, and Sam saw him tense. "Did you see it as well, Teal'c?"

"Yes."

"What did you see?" Adora asked.

"A large creature hiding behind a hut," the Colonel replied.

"More than one," Entrapta said. "My scanner detects about a dozen surrounding us." She looked up. "And they are all about as large as Adora."

Melog growled.

*****

The Ruins

Ruins near crashed Al-Kesh, PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

A dozen creatures? As large as Adora? In her She-Ra form? Catra refrained from scoffing. She couldn't be overconfident. That way lay defeat. And death. But, still… "Creatures?" she asked.

"Looked like… some bear," O'Neill replied. "Just sleeker."

"Like a big cat, though without a tail," Teal'c added.

Had O'Neill hesitated to call it a cat because of her and Melog? Catra snorted. As if she'd take offence to that. "So, they've got us surrounded," she said. "Smart of them."

"That's typical pack predator behaviour," Daniel pointed out. "It's mostly instinct."

Melog growled. *Goa'uld*. *One*.

Catra tensed. "Melog's sensing a Goa'uld," she hissed.

"A Goa'uld? But we haven't…" Daniel trailed off. "So they did take an animal as host!" he blurted out.

That was obvious, of course.

"And they are the leader of a pack of man-sized predators. Amazon-sized, actually," O'Neill said, nodding at Adora.

Catra snorted at the mention of those mythical warrior-women from Earth. So much to tease Adora about.

Adora frowned. "What are they doing?"

"They're coming closer - they're using the ruins as cover," Entrapta said.

"Tell us before they get on the roof," O'Neill said. "They might attempt to draw our attention to the front, where we can see them, and sneak up on us from behind."

That would be a good tactic - there were no windows at the back. Catra looked up at the roof. It had several holes in it.

"Don't!" Adora hissed.

Catra rolled her eyes at her lover. "I can handle a creature or two." Especially with her shock-rod.

"Leave them to me. You go after the Goa'uld with Melog."

Catra blinked. That was actually a better plan than ambushing some creatures on the roof. But… "You're going to play distraction, right?"

Adora grinned at her. "Of course."

Catra gritted her teeth. It made sense, but she loathed it. Adora was risking herself again - or sacrificing herself.

"No one's rushing out without a plan!" O'Neill snapped.

"Just hurry up with the plan," Entrapta said. "They're almost here." Her hair pointed at the wall in the back.

"Oh for…" O'Neill clenched his teeth. "Adora, take them on the roof. We'll keep the front clear."

"And we're going to sneak out in the confusion and grab the leader," Catra said, patting Melog on the head.

Yes, they growled.

"Let's do it!" Adora jumped before she finished talking, straight through a hole in the roof, her shoulders knocking dirt and stone fragments loose as they pushed against the edges of the hole.

A moment later, a dozen creatures roared, and Entrapta yelled: "They're coming!"

Catra heard a dull noise followed by a screech - Adora had swatted or kicked one creature off the roof. Shaking her head, she looked at the hole herself, then jumped.

She had no problem fitting through the hole and easily landed on all fours on the roof, drawing her shock-rod at once. But Adora had the situation in hand - and one of the creatures, holding it at the neck while it tried to twist enough to reach her with its claws. Another jumped on the roof, claws the size of Catra's fingers digging into the stone as it turned to attack her.

Catra dashed forward, her own claws keeping her from slipping, and hit it with the shock-rod. The creature howled, froze for a moment, then collapsed.

"Catra!" Adora snapped, kicking another creature off the roof.

"I had to check if it worked," Catra defended herself.

Hunt.

Melog jumped off the roof.

Catra sighed and followed them. Behind her, shots rang out and the sounds of staff-weapon fire. And more howling. Well, she had a task to do. A snake to hunt down.

Melog was ahead, turning around the corner of the next hut, and Catra ran faster to catch up. Cover worked both ways, but Melog could sense the Goa'uld.

They weaved through the village, the sounds of fighting not lessening. The howling didn't stop either. That was how the Goa'uld led the others, Catra realised. That meant they were watching the fight.

She spotted the creature on the roof of the building at the edge of the village when they were about twenty yards away still. If they were fixated on the fighting, they could take them from behind by surprise.

Danger! Melog hissed.

Catra whirled. One of the creatures was pouncing on her, already in the air, claws out. Catra threw herself to the side, lashing out with her shock-rod but missing the creature as it flew past, crashing into the ground a yard away.

It quickly turned around, howling, but Catra was already moving towards it. Its claws dug into the earth, muscles twitching - Catra dropped to the ground, sliding the last yard as the creature jumped overhead. She rammed the rod straight up. This time, she didn't miss, and the creature collapsed in a heap behind her.

But the Goa'uld had watched - and was turning away. Trying to run. Melog was already racing toward it.

Catra cursed and gave chase.

*****

Jack O'Neill fired a burst at the creature charging at the hut, catching it in mid-leap. The cat-thing roared and hit the dirt, rolling around with flailing limbs. Teal'c put a shot with his staff into it, and it fell silent. That was the third they had taken down so far.

The rest of the creatures withdrew back behind the huts around them. Smart. Too smart for Jack's taste. "Are we sure that those aren't Goa'uld?" he asked as he switched his magazine.

"I do not sense anything, Sir," Carter replied from the other side of the room.

That would have to do with the cat-detector away. "OK, we're currently holding the hut, but not doing any better…" he started to

say.

“They’re leaving!” Entrapta blurted out.

“What?” Jack turned to look down the street. He caught a shadow moving behind the huts. “Running north?”

“Yes!”

Damn. “They’re after Catra!” Jack snapped. “We need to…”

Once more, he was interrupted.

“Catra!” Adora yelled. Then the hut shook a little, and dirt fell down from the roof - the amazon must have jumped off.

A moment later, he saw Adora land in the middle of the ‘street’ and running towards Catra’s last known position.

Great.

“Should we move after them?” Teal’c asked.

“This might be a trap,” Jack pointed out. “If we get caught in the open by those monsters…”

Daniel winced as Carter nodded in agreement.

“On the other hand, we just lost our roof cover,” Jack went on. “If the creatures return, we can’t keep them out.” He looked at Teal’c. “You take point. Daniel, Entrapta, Carter - after him. I will bring up the rear.”

Teal’c was already out and moving, not nearly as fast as he could run. Jack shooed Daniel and Entrata out, then nodded at Carter.

The dust thrown up by Adora was just settling when Jack left the hut, scanning left and right with his M4 at the ready. “The creatures are still headed north,” Entrapta said.

“Good. Move it!”

Teal’c sped up a little, and they quickly passed the next huts. Jack caught a glimpse of Adora at the last hut - she was…

…throwing one of the creatures away. High enough so Jack didn’t think the monster would survive the experience. “I bet she could out-mortar a mortar,” he commented as they closed in on the last hut. He wasn’t sure if he was joking.

“Catra!” Adora yelled again. Two creatures were on the ground next to her, Jack saw.

“We need to catch the Goa’uld!” That was Catra. But he couldn’t see her from this spot.

Jack clenched his teeth.

Adora jumped over the hut, presumably after Catra, and more howling and growling followed.

Teal’c cleared the corner and raised his staff, firing before Jack reached him. A howling noise told him that Teal’c had hit one of the creatures.

“Carter, keep them safe!” Jack snapped before he turned the corner, keeping low.

Something moved in the bush to his right, and Jack almost put a burst into it. But he didn’t know where the two cats on his side were.

The creature crashing through the bush was neither Catra nor Melog, and Jack fired another burst at it as he dived to the side.

The monster overshot, sliding a few yards from sheer momentum, and as it whirled, Carter put several rounds into it. It collapsed in a growing pool of blood.

Another ran out from the back of the hut, claws digging into the soil, but Jack stopped it with a burst to the head before it could

close with them. A third tried to run, but Teal'c got it before it reached the next bush.

Jack stood as Teal'c passed him. "How many of them are left?"

"Uh… three! Not including the one Catra and Adora are chasing!" Entrapta replied.

Three? They could take three.

"One on the roof!" Entrapta yelled.

Jack whirled, raising his gun, as the monster jumped off the roof, straight at him. Jack's rounds went wide as he dived into a combat roll forward, barely avoiding the claws of the thing.

He came up with his M4 swinging around, but the monster was too fast. Instead of shooting it, Jack slammed the muzzle of his gun into the side of its head.

And that didn't stop it from crashing into him.

Jack tried to roll with the punch and pulled his legs in, kicking out as he hit the ground, and the creature flew past him - directly in the blast of Teal'c's staff.

That was… Jack hissed in pain, checking his chest. The claws had sliced through his vest and webbing and into his shoulder. It bled, but it wasn't very deep - it only hurt a little...

"Colonel!"

"Jack!"

"There are two left!" Jack snapped.

"One," Entrapta corrected him. "And it's running north."

Then Carter was opening his vest and pushing it away, revealing his wound. She winced.

“It’s not bad,” Jack told her. It didn’t really hurt much.

Carter shook her head.

“Jack!” Daniel hissed. “I can see the bone!”

“What?” That made no sense. That would hurt a lot more.

Jack blinked. It didn’t hurt at all, now. “Oh. My side’s going numb.”

“The claws must have some poison!” Carter spat through clenched teeth.

“Antidote!” Daniel snapped, patting his webbing down.

“I doubt it’s a nerve gas,” Jack told him. And if it wasn’t, then the antidote would only make things worse.

“Adora!” Entrapta yelled. “Jack’s hurt badly!”

A moment later, her voice, much, much louder, repeated her words.

Jack blinked again, then grinned. “That’s a real handy thing…” He snorted, then coughed. Breathing got kind of harder…

*****

“Adora! Jack’s hurt badly!”

Adora clenched her teeth as she heard Entrapta’s shout. The fleeing Goa’uld and his last creature were barely ahead of her - she could see them. She had almost caught up. But Entrapta wouldn’t yell like this if Jack didn’t need help right now.

“Go! We can handle them!” Catra passed her, Melog at her side.

Adora cursed under her breath. They were right. She loathed it - Catra was risking herself fighting two of those creatures, one of them a Goa’uld - but they were right.

“Don’t get killed!” she yelled and turned around, running all-out back to the ruins.

The area was littered with the corpses of the creatures, many of them smoking - SG-1 had taken out a lot of them. But… there! Jack was on the ground, Carter kneeling with him and… kissing him? No, breathing into his mouth.

“He’s been poisoned,” Entrapta told her. “The claws of the creatures are coated with venom.”

They were? Adora hadn’t noticed. Then again, she hadn’t let them scratch her. Her eyes widened, and she looked back over her shoulder. Catra didn’t know about that!

“His body is shutting down,” Carter gasped before breathing into Jack’s mouth again.

“We’ve got an antidote, but we don’t know if it’ll help or make it worse,” Daniel said.

“My scans are inconclusive - I’ve never encountered this kind of venom before,” Entrapta added, biting her lower lip. “So…”

Adora nodded and pointed her sword at Jack. Then she closed her eyes and focused on her magic. Her power. Jack needed to be healed.

She opened her eyes again, and a wave of magic shot out from the tip of her sword and into Jack.

He tensed, gasping and choking, his eyes shooting open, while her magic worked on him. After a few seconds, she lowered her sword.

Jack gulped down air, panting and coughing. “That… that was…”

“Sir! Don’t move!” Carter snapped. “You’re hurt and poisoned.”

“I don’t feel hurt any more,” Jack replied, blinking. He glanced at the bandage on his chest. “And I don’t feel numb any more either.”

“Sir!”

“Jack!”

But Jack pulled the bandage away, revealing smooth skin underneath it. “So that’s magical healing. Wow.”

Adora nodded. “I can heal people.” And plants. And animals, probably.

“Thanks. I thought I was a goner.” He smiled, then looked at Carter. “Kept me alive, huh?”

“I rendered first aid, but…” Carter tilted her head. “We were about to hit you with an antidote.”

“Ah.” Jack nodded.

Adora looked at Entrapta. “Any trace of the poison left?”

“Uh… not that I can tell. But I didn’t notice the venom on their claws before.”

Adra nodded. “I’ll be back.” She dashed away. Catra was still out there, alone with just Melog, fighting creatures with poisoned claws. If anything happened to her…

She ran through scraggly bushes, up a dune - there were tracks in the sand! Pawprints and Catra’s footprints. From the crest of the dune, she could see a forest in the distance - and Catra fighting a creature. Damn!

Adora ran as fast as she could, down the slope, cursing at the sand slowing her down. Catra needed her help!

She panted as she reached the bottom of the dune, briefly losing sight of Catra, then sped up, sand getting thrown up with every step she took. She reached the next crest, and there was Catra, facing a creature trying to circle around her. Her shock-rod crackled, but the creature jumped back.

Adora snarled and charged with her sword. The creature saw her coming and whirled, trying to flee, but Adora threw her sword. The blade caught it in mid-jump, spearing its side, and the creature collapsed in the sand.

"Melog's gone after the Goa'uld!" Catra snapped.

Careful! They have poison on their claws!" Adora told her as she summoned her sword again.

"Really?" Catra scoffed. "This way."

"Jack almost died," Adora told her as they raced up the next dune, following Melog's tracks.

"I heard Entrapta yelling."

That wasn't the point! "Let me fight it!" Adora snapped.

"I've got the shock-rod! We need the Goa'uld alive!"

"I can take them alive!" Adora could!

"And what if you get poisoned? Who's going to heal you?" Catra snarled.

"I won't get poisoned."

"Neither will I!" Catra shot back.

They reached the crest of the next dune and stopped. The Goa'uld wasn't moving any more - it was standing in the sand, looking at… nothing?

"Oh!" Catra whispered. "Melog got it caught in an illusion."

Right. Melog could do that.

Catra grinned. “See? Easy!” She sauntered - sauntered! - down the slope, walking casually up to the Goa’uld, twirling her shock-rod.

Adora followed her, scowling. This was too easy.

Catra smirked at her. Then she stuck the creature in the side. Crackling electricity warped over the creature, and it howled.

But it didn’t go down - it whirled, lashing out with its claws.

Catra jumped back, snarling, and dodged the swipe. “Want another one? Here!” She lunged, giving the creature another shock. “Tough bastard!”

This time, the creature went down, twitching and groaning. They had… It opened its mouth, and a small thing flew out of it - and at Catra.

Before Adora could react, Catra swatted at it with her free hand - and sliced it in half with her claws. “Damn,” she spat, grimacing at the sight of a bisected snake in the sand.

“So much for catching them alive,” Adora said.

“It was a reflex!” Catra defended herself. “I didn’t expect the idiot to charge me like that!”

“Right!”

*****

The Colonel was safe. Healed. Samantha Carter couldn’t help staring at his chest. Instead of a gaping wound that exposed the bones beneath, there was only smooth skin covering muscles. She raised her hand, then lowered it. She wouldn’t poke the skin like some… whatever.

“Amazing,” Daniel whispered. “I mean, they told us about magical healing, but to see it like this…”

“We’ve seen Goa’uld healing devices before,” the Colonel said. He was poking his chest, of course, and Sam couldn’t help thinking that he looked a little shaken. “Remember Kendra?”

“But she required a Goa’uld Healing Device,” Daniel replied. “This was just magic. Unless the sword is a healing device.”

“You know of devices that can heal?” Entrapta stepped in front of Daniel and the Colonel, eyes shining. “Without magic?”

“Yessss?” The Colonel looked like he was facing down another dangerous creature.

“Fascinating! Where can we get them? It would revolutionise healthcare if we didn’t need sorceresses any more for healing!”

“Well, from the Goa’uld, but I believe they are quite rare,” Daniel told her. “And you need a high concentration of Naquadah in your blood to use them, or so we believe.”

That was the common theory, Sam knew. If it was true, then she might be able to use such a device herself, after her possession. She wasn’t quite sure if that was a good or bad thing - she was a scientist, not a doctor.

“Really?”

“The only one we saw using one was a former Goa’uld host,” the Colonel said as he tried to close his shirt. Which Sam had cut off in her haste to save him.

“Oh. I wonder how that works. In any case, that shouldn’t be a problem - we can insert Naquadah into people’s bodies, can’t we? In safe doses.” Entrapta leaned forward with a smile.

“Well…” The Colonel grimaced and looked at Sam.

“We don’t know if that is possible without a Goa’uld being present in the body, nor do we know what would be a safe dose,” she explained.

“Then we’ll have to find out!” Entrapta beamed at her. “This will be great!”

“We would have to find a Goa’uld with such a device, first,” the Colonel said. “I doubt that anyone on this planet has such a device.”

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded. “Absent a Goa’uld, such a mission would not have included such a device.”

“Yeah, right. So, has anyone seen our resident magical girl?” The Colonel looked around as he pulled on his webbing. Or tried to. Sam had cut through that as well.

“Oh, let me fix that!” Entrapta’s hair reached out and pulled the damaged webbing to her - and with it the Colonel.

“Hey!”

“It won’t take long!” And the princess was wielding pliers and… was that a welding kit?

Sam took a step closer and watched while she reattached the torn webbing.

“There!”

“Uh, thanks.” The Colonel looked bemused. “But honestly, where are Adora and Catra?”

“Oh!” Entrapta pulled out her main tool - Sam really had to copy that - and fiddled with it. “They’re… coming back to us.”

And there they were. Adora and Catra, and Melog. They looked unhurt, but Catra looked angry, and Adora looked… amused?

“Did the snake get away?” the Colonel asked.

“Not exactly,” Adora replied, glancing at Catra.

Catra rolled her eyes. “They surprised me, and…” She held up her hand. A Goa’uld dangled from it. No, two halves of a Goa’uld dangled from her fingers.

“Ah.” The Colonel nodded. “Better safe than sorry, trust me - you don’t want a snake burrowing into you.

Sam shuddered at the memories that brought up.

“Would’ve still been great to capture one for interrogation,” Catra said.

“They would’ve needed a host to communicate,” Sam pointed out.

“We could’ve stuck them in an animal and made them write out answers,” Catra replied. “Well, there should be other snakes on the planet, right? One per dead Jaffa?”

“Unless they fought amongst each other,” Daniel told her. With a grimace, he added: “This one might have consumed the others.”

“Ew.” Catra and Adora made faces. Catra frowned at the corpse.

“Well, we can still find out information from a corpse!” Entrapta said.

Sam hoped she meant an autopsy. But with magic - and with Entrapta - it was hard to tell.

“Go wild,” Catra said, handing the two parts over.

“Yes!” Entrapta’s head bopped as she nodded.

“But maybe do that after we searched the tombs?” Daniel asked. “Searched for them, I mean.”

“The dead won’t move,” Catra told him.

“But if there are more Goa’uld survivors on the planet, then they will now know of our presence here,” Daniel retorted. “We should find the graveyard quickly. Before more of those creatures arrive.”

That was a good argument.

“I’ll have to preserve the corpse, though,” Entrapta said. “Let’s go back to the shuttle and put it in the freezer!”

“The freezer?” The Colonel asked with a grin. “Not some fancy magical stasis field?”

“Oh, no. Those require a sorcerer or sorceress to set up,” Entrapta replied. “That’s kinda bothersome if you don’t have one with you.”

“Ah, of course.” The Colonel forced a smile on his face.

Sam couldn’t help but grin at this - he should know better than to assume anything about the Etherians by now.

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Crashed Al-Kesh, PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Standing on the ramp of the shuttle, Catra fiddled with the sanitiser. Blood on her claws was the worst. If she forgot about it and retracted her claws, it would get all icky. And if she didn’t, it dried, and she had to scrape it off her claws. Which was a pain with both claws out.

“Let me help.” Adora reached out to her.

Catra turned away with a scowl. “I can clean myself up, thank you very much.” She didn’t need any help - this should be natural. She’d done it before, even once when she had hurt Adora, and… Not going there.

“Please!”

Perhaps she should start licking the claws clean. That would show Adora that she wasn't helpless.

"Let me do this for you." Adora grabbed her shoulder and gently turned her around.

Catra found herself staring at Adora's smiling face. So close to her own, and so… so… "Fine!" she spat, feeling herself blush a little as she thrust both claws and bottle into her lover's face.

Adora beamed at her and quickly started cleaning her claws.

Catra tried not to fidget too much. This reminded her of the time she had gotten her hand hurt in training, and Adora had sneaked a bottle of disinfectant to treat it.

She wasn't quite sure how to feel about that.

"There!"

Catra flexed her claws, cocking her head to inspect them, then retracted them and unsheathed them several times in a row. "Looks fine." She bared her fangs. "I can slice the next snake now."

"Catra!"

"I'm joking!" she said and nodded at the interior of the shuttle. "Did they store the corpse?"

"I think so." Adora frowned. "Didn't you hear them?"

She had been distracted. Catra shrugged. "I was focusing on watching you."

"Oh."

Now Adora was blushing as well.

"Alright! Now that the snake's on ice, let's go check the graveyard, so Daniel stops fidgeting."

“Jack!”

“What? You were fidgeting.”

“We only have an approximative location,” Catra heard Daniel complain as the others approached them. “We don’t know if the tombs are there - or if there are tombs. Some cultures leave their dead for the carrion eaters.”

Ew. That sounded gross.

“What’s wrong, Catra?”

Catra turned to look at Adora. “Daniel just explained that some people leave their dead for the carrion eaters to dispose of.”

“Ew!”

“It’s actually a fascinating religious practice,” Daniel explained as he stepped on the ramp. “And not any grosser than, say, mummification.”

“Mummification?” Adora asked.

Daniel explained.

Ew. Those Earth people were weird.

“Anyway, we’re going to fly to the location,” Daniel said. “So…”

“Yeah, let’s go,” Catra said.

The flight didn’t take long - a minute including take-off and landing - and soon they were looking at a hill.

“Well, there are empty spaces inside the hill, according to my scanner. So, either natural caves or tombs,” Entrapta said.

“And they hid the entrance?” Adora asked.

“Probably to deter grave robbers, although that seems not quite effective if scanners still show the graves. And, of course, if the graves were meant to be found by their system lord, hiding the entrance without some hint or clue might be counter-productive,” Daniel explained. “The closeness to the wreck would make it easy to find.”

“Yeah, yeah. The question is: Can we find the entrance?” O’Neill asked.

“It should be here,” Entrapta said, pointing ahead. “There’s a tunnel behind the rock there.”

Catra turned to Adora. “Well, get moving and lifting.”

Adora pouted at her but started walking towards the rock. Catra followed her, together with the others.

The rock was double the size of her and didn’t seem to have any convenient handholds - probably rolled in place with the help of a lever. Adora didn’t bother with either - she reached around it, grabbed it somehow, and heaved.

She turned, took a step and dropped the rock on the ground, where it rolled a little to the side.

Catra was already looking at the tunnel opening she had revealed. It was rough - almost like a natural cave. But the walls and the ceiling were…

“They must have burned their way in. This wasn’t drilled or built,” Daniel said.

“Yeah. I didn’t expect stonework after the mud huts,” O’Neill commented. “But this must have cost a lot of power.”

“Several staff weapons’ worth,” Teal’c confirmed.

“So…” O’Neill looked at them. “It was important.”

"Yes." Daniel nodded.

"Not important enough to make nice walls with big hieroglyphs praising their lord, though," O'Neill went on.

Daniel blinked. "That might just be the entrance, trying to look natural."

"With a big rock in front of it. And people would still explore a natural cave. It's what we do." O'Neill shook his head.

Catra agreed with him. Who wouldn't explore a cave like this, natural or not? "So, it's trapped."

O'Neill grinned. "I think so. And I doubt it's a big round rock that Daniel can outrun."

"Jack!"

"You'd need a hat and a whip, anyway."

"Jack!"

Ah. Again a reference to the 'movie' they mentioned. "So… do we spring the trap, or do we try to find it and dismantle it?" Catra asked.

"I would suggest we do it the way that won't get us hurt," O'Neill replied with a toothy smile.

Of course, Adora just had to speak up. "Oh, I think I can take it."

*****

Tombs, PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Playing Indiana Jones. It wasn't the first time, it probably wouldn't be the last, but it wasn't funny and would never be. Jack O'Neill knew that. The snakes - the Jaffa, in this case - would have left some nasty surprises to deal with anyone entering whatever they

had been hiding here who wasn't their master. And now Adora was talking tough.

"You might be wrong," Jack told her. "The Jaffa probably rigged this to defend against the Goa'uld you killed."

"Yes?" Adora looked as if she didn't get what that meant.

"It means that whatever measures they took, they planned to defend against a supernaturally tough creature that could keep coming at them as long as they survived to possess a new body," Carter explained.

"Resetting traps?" Daniel, of course, looked surprised. "How would they manage that? Without us detecting that, I mean."

Which was a good question. Jack looked at Carter.

"They could have found a way to shield the traps' power supplies. Or they might have used an Ancient Device. That is less likely, of course. And I doubt they would have anticipated magical sensors. But the most obvious solution is that they would have rigged a charge to destroy the entire facility in case of an unauthorised breach," Carter said.

That, at last, gave Adora pause. And made Catra scowl. "See?" the catwoman said. "Don't blindly charge in."

"I wasn't planning to!" Adora retorted. "But if anything goes wrong, I'm the one most likely to survive it."

"You're also the one most likely to heal people if something goes wrong," Catra shot back.

"Right. So how about we don't risk people at all?" Jack asked, looking at Entrapta.

"Oh! I can rig up a remote-controlled bot! That way, we don't risk anyone getting hurt!" The Princess beamed. "Though my scanners don't show any bomb big in the hill. No Naquadah. No reactor."

“Did you check for chemical charges?” Jack asked.

“Oh…” Entrapta pulled out her scanner thingie again. “Oh! There’s some large space filled with a compound that would combust very easily.”

“They’ve rigged the tomb to blow,” Jack said.

“But what are they hiding in there if it doesn’t have Naquadah?” Daniel shook his head. “Ancient Tech is based on that metal, isn’t it?”

“Normally, yes,” Carter told him. “But there’s no indication that they had to use it for everything. Although if they didn’t, the odds of anything surviving so long are… not very high.”

“You can say ‘zero’, Carter,” Jack said.

“There’s always a chance, Sir.”

He didn’t sigh, but he smiled. “Yes. And we’ve found that out the hard way before. So… we need to find a way to defuse that bomb. Preferably without standing in front of the tunnel opening, which will channel the blast.” He turned to Entrapta. “Show me the data, please.”

To her credit, she didn’t argue and showed him the setup with a portable holographic display. The geeks at Stargate Command would faint if offered such a device. Focus, Jack, he reminded himself. He wasn’t a scientist, and he had no clue about Ancient Tech, but he knew a lot about explosives. And if Entrapta’s magic scanner didn’t pick up Naquadah or anything nuclear, then the Jaffa must have used chemical explosives to trap the tomb. Maybe even homebrewed from stuff available in the ship.

And Jack was quite familiar with those kinds of explosives. Had brewed up some of his own on some missions. He studied the plans, walking around the display. There was a thin wall between the explosives and the rest of the installation. The explosion would completely wreck the area. Might crack the hill too - Jack

had seen what happened to underground armouries if something blew up. “We need to get a lot further away to be safe,” he said. “Unless we want to risk getting crushed by flying debris the size of tanks.”

“I can protect us against that,” Adora said.

Catra elbowed her. “You don’t have to because we’ll be safe in the shuttle.”

“And how do you disarm it?” Entrapta asked. “It looks like the trigger here is… oh… connected to the trigger there, and…”

“Interconnected triggers,” Jack said. “Rigged to blow if anyone single one gets tampered with. But they’re old. Might not work as planned any more.”

“And the chemicals might have degraded,” Carter added.

“Becoming inert - or unstable,” Jack said. They would have to be very, very careful there. “You don’t have a way to magically turn explosives into plants or so?”

“Uh…” Adora bit her lower lip. “I don’t think so.”

Pity. That would’ve been great.

“Then we need to take out all triggers simultaneously,” Jack said.

“Oh! Multiple remote-controlled bots!” Entrapta beamed. “That should be a challenge. Although I suppose if I program them correctly, they can all execute a predetermined sequence of actions at the same time. Each would need their own code, of course, and the signal lag…”

“Since signal lag will be a factor, but the orders won’t be time-critical,” Carter cut in, “what about having synchronised clocks in each bot, so they can execute orders at the same time?”

“Obviously, yes! Though we might have to repurpose some scanners to synchronise the clocks. Perhaps if we use a crystal as the…”

Jack purposely tuned the technobabble out. It wasn’t as if he would be able to follow it once the two women started discussing the nuts and bolts of the task. “Alright, folks - let’s move to the shuttle for safety’s sake,” he said, clapping his hands.

As safe as you could be, at least, when Carter and Entrapta started building experimental tech.

*****

“They’re still at it.”

Sitting on the shuttle’s ramp, looking at the hill, Adora turned her head and looked at Catra as her lover joined her, handing over a cup of tea. “Thanks.”

She took the cup in both hands and sipped. Almost too hot. Adora blew on the liquid.

Catra snorted and swallowed half her own cup.

“Cats are supposed to be more sensitive to heat.”

Catra snorted as Daniel joined them, another cup of tea in his hand. “Cat’s aren’t supposed to do what they are supposed to do,” she said.

“Touché,” Daniel replied.

“‘Touché’?” Adora tilted her head at him.

“It’s an expression from fencing; it means you scored a point - touched your opponent,” Daniel explained. “Fencing as, ah, a competitive sport, not the actual fighting.”

Ah. Adora nodded. That made more sense than what she had thought the first time.

"So, what do you think the Jaffa hid in the tomb? If it's even a tomb."

"Well, there's no Naquadah - unless they found a way to shield it," Daniel said. "So, I doubt that there's a stasis pod containing another Goa'uld."

"And no Naquadah-based technology," Adora said.

"We shouldn't assume that they couldn't shield Naquadah," Catra said.

"The Goa'uld don't know about magic," Daniel objected. "How can you shield something against something that you don't even know exists, much less how it works?"

"By accident," Catra said. "Drove the instructors crazy if you did something that wrecked their plans while trying something else."

Adora snorted. "You mean: 'while *appearing* to try something else'," she corrected her lover.

Catra flashed her a toothy grin.

"Ah." Daniel nodded. "I had the impression that Horde training methods were rather rigid."

"The Horde's whole damn doctrine was rigid," Catra muttered. "We did a lot better when I started to mix things up."

"Yes." Adora pressed her lips together. She didn't want to talk about the Horde. "But if it's not Naquadah, what could it be? They were sent to recover Stargates, weren't they?"

"According to what we know, yes," Daniel said.

“They were recovering Stargates so that Horde Prime or the First Ones couldn’t get them,” Catra said. “Did anyone analyse what weapons shot the ship?”

“Sam - Captain Carter - said that the spectral analysis didn’t match any known weapon systems,” Daniel said.

“So they weren’t shot at by other Goa’uld since we know their weapons thanks to you. And you guys got the data on Horde Prime weapons and Darla’s weapons, meaning First Ones,” Catra said. “That leaves…?”

“...unknown weapons,” Adora replied.

“Or First Ones that we don’t know yet,” Catra added. “But yes, probably unknown weapons.”

“A new species or culture, perhaps?” Daniel beamed.

Adora sighed and looked at Catra, who was not quite snarling.

“Did I miss something?” Daniel asked.

“You know what Horde Prime did to planets whose population resisted?” Catra asked.

And likely to planets that didn’t resist.

Daniel blinked. “Oh. And since they were shooting at a Goa’uld ship, they would likely have resisted Horde Prime as well.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “If they took anything with the Stargate, it might be the last remnants of a destroyed planet. And they obviously didn’t think that the Stargate was more important since they didn’t hide it.”

“They might not have been able to hide it. If they could hide a Stargate, then they can hide Naquadah from sensors, and all bets are off,” Catra pointed out.

“Right.” Adora nodded. “We’ll find out once the others have the bots ready.”

“It’s actually more of a drone since they cannot make any decisions autonomously,” Daniel said.

Adora snorted and shook her head. As if that difference mattered.

*****

“Alright! We’ve got the bots all ready. Well, they are technically not bots since their programming isn’t complex enough, so it’s more like…”

“They are remote-controlled drones,” Sam said.

Entrapta pouted for a moment, then nodded. “And we’re going to send them inside to find and disable all bombs and other traps in the tomb!”

“Carefully,” Jack said. “Very carefully.”

“Yes,” Daniel agreed. “We don’t want to destroy whatever is hidden in this hill.”

“We won’t! We’ve found the traps already, thanks to our scanner!” Entrapta said. “Jack just has to defuse them all!”

“No pressure,” Jack mumbled as he sat down at the screen that Sam and Entrapta had rigged up to control the bots. “The worst that can happen is that everything blows up.”

“Including the planet,” Teal’c commented, which earned him a nasty glare from Jack.

Adora didn’t think it was funny either. You didn’t joke about blowing up planets.

She blinked. Teal’c didn’t joke as a rule, did he?

*****

The Hill

Tombs, PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Was that a joke about blowing a planet?" Samantha Carter heard Adora ask.

She shook her head. "With enough Naquadah to enhance an explosion, it's possible. Not likely since there are much easier and cheaper ways to scorch a planet, but possible." Sam had done the calculations herself, once. Just in case. Earth didn't have enough Naquadah to blow up a planet, but it wouldn't take a second Manhattan Project to achieve the necessary amount. Just a focus on gathering the metal.

"Ra had a planet blown up at least once, to make an example out of a rebellious subordinate," Teal'c added.

"We'll have to take that into account when we plan Earth's protection," Adora said. "And Etheria's."

"Depending on how big such a bomb is, we'll need a way to intercept bombers such as this Al'Kesh," Catra added.

"You need interceptors," the Colonel said with a grin. "I've been saying that for a long time. Those Death Gliders just don't cut it."

"They serve the System Lords well enough," Teal'c said.

"And they are proven design," Sam added.

"Yeah, but they are ugly, and they don't exactly fit our doctrine," the Colonel retorted. "I'm sure you can come up with a better design. Multi-role aircraft. Aerospace craft."

"Spacecraft design isn't amongst my primary duties or experience," Sam told him and straightened.

“Oh! But it sounds like fun! I’m sure we can come up with some nice designs!” Entrapta piped up. “Multi-role, you said? It would probably be hard to design one that could replace a frigate, but it should be able to replace the Al’Kesh and Death Glider. Bomber and interceptor? Oh, I’ve got some ideas…”

“Make sure it looks good,” the Colonel said, and the princess nodded eagerly. “Like an F-15.”

Sam couldn’t tell if he was joking.

“I hate to interrupt this design committee, but could we get on with defusing the massive bomb in the hill across of us?” Daniel said.

“Right, right.” The Colonel took a deep breath and sat down in front of the screen that showed the drones’ camera feeds. “Let’s do it.” He briefly flexed his fingers and took control of the first drone.

He hadn’t piloted such a drone before, but there was no sense of uncertainty or hesitation that Sam could spot - the drone flew straight towards the open cave, smoothly entered it and then slowed down as it travelled further inside. “Alright,” he said. “Now, how do those manipulators work?”

“Oh, let me show you.” Entrapta almost climbed into his lap as she took the controls and demonstrated.

Sam pressed her lips together and shook her head; the Colonel even blushed. But he quickly started using the manipulator arms - Sam had taken notes of the design; the vehicles at Stargate Command could use those as well - and started approaching what seemed to be the first trap.

“Alright. I need some x-ray vision here.”

“There!” A strand of hair darted forward, and the stone wall on the screen turned transparent. As impressive as it looked, Sam had a few ideas about how she could make that more efficient

once she had access to her lab in Cheyenne Mountain. The Etherians were a little behind Earth in displaying sensor readings. Though they had HUDs, in as much as Entrapta's visor could copy the functionality, they were not widespread.

The Colonel studied the screen, then pointed at one line. "Can you check where this one leads?"

Sam leaned forward. The line led straight back to the main chemical storage and to what looked like a detonator. Although it was also connected to other lines. "I think that's the line to cut, Sir," she said.

"I think so as well - one of them, at least. Alright, let's drill. Carefully."

Sam glanced at Daniel while the Colonel used the laser drill Sam and Entrapta had rigged up. Her friend was biting his lower lip so hard, she expected him to hurt himself any moment.

"Daniel, relax, we're safe here," Adora told him with a smile and in a low voice that the Colonel wouldn't hear. "Even if the entire hill blows up, the shields will protect us."

Sam hid a smile of her own at Daniel's surprised reaction and denials. "I'm not worried about our safety."

Catra loudly snorted.

Daniel pouted. "I am worried about what we may lose should the hill be destroyed."

Catra shrugged. "If it gets destroyed, we'll never know what it was, so why worry?"

Daniel gaped at her. He took a deep breath, no doubt to lecture her, when the Colonel snapped: "Could you keep it down a little? Defusing bombs is a delicate business."

Daniel's mouth snapped shut so quickly, Sam had to hide another grin.

The Colonel wasn't even paying attention any more - he was already piloting the next drone to the next trigger. "I could really get used to this," he commented. "Flying drones and see-through-walls sensors? Intel would kill for this."

"They don't have to," Entrapta said. "We can show them how to build them! It's easy!"

For Entrapta. Although Sam was sure she could duplicate the drones as well, except for the magical sensor. That she would have to procure from Entrapta.

Unless the Colonel could be convinced to learn how to build them. She almost snickered at the thought of his reaction if she made such a proposal. And then she imagined what would happen if the brass did this, and her amusement vanished. Depending on how rare such a talent was amongst humans on Earth, this could very well happen.

*****

Catra narrowed her eyes as she watched O'Neill work. It was impressive to see him pilot the bots like that, but it was also quite informative. He was a good fighter on the ground and a good pilot. Which was a good thing since a single mistake would end up with the hill blowing up. Of course they didn't know what the Jaffa had hidden inside the complex, so she shouldn't really be bothered or care overly much about it. But still…

She glanced at Adora, who was biting her lower lip as she watched. "Relax," she whispered, repeating Adora's own words. "We're safe here."

That made Adora glare at her - but she wasn't trying to pierce her lips any more. "I'm aware of that."

"Good."

Catra smiled and patted Adora's back before returning to watch O'Neill - just in time to see him lean back and sigh.

"Alright, I think that's it. Now, all we have to do is to cut all the lines at the same time."

"Yes!" Entrapta grinned widely - and slightly derangedly. "Now, we can find out if my program works!"

"'Now'?" O'Neill asked.

"We've tested it. Sir," Carter told him.

"Ah."

"But this is the first live test!" Entrapta's hair twitched. "Ready?"

"Go ahead."

"Yes!" She reached out and pushed a button. The screen split into half a dozen cameras, one of them showing the outside of the hill. Then she pushed another button, and lasers hit five lines.

Catra held her breath, but the hill didn't blow up. She released it silently.

Daniel's relieved sigh was much louder, of course.

"OK, they worked!" Entrapta nodded. "So… let's go inside!"

"Let's keep the drones working," O'Neill corrected her. "There's still enough explosives in that hill to vaporise it - to use a scientific term."

"I do not think the explosives are powerful enough to turn the stone and rock into vapour," Teal'c told him.

"It's a figure of speech, Teal'c."

"I see."

Catra narrowed her eyes a little - was the big guy joking? It was very hard to tell. But O'Neill had the right idea - better to risk a bot than a person. Although he might've just wanted to keep piloting the bots.

The screen changed again, only showing one perspective now - the one of the bot O'Neill piloted. He manoeuvred it down the tunnel until it met a door.

"It's a wooden door," Entrapta said. "I don't see any traps on it."

"Not a lock, either, though - they just put a metal block in and welded it closed," O'Neill said.

"Probably with a staff weapon," Carter said.

"But was it to keep people out - or to keep whatever is inside from getting out? Let's find out." O'Neill moved the manipulator arm up, and a laser hit the hinges. "If you want to keep someone out, you put the hinges on the other side…"

"Jaffa are generally not the best architects - at least the ones trusted with such missions," Teal'c said.

Catra didn't comment. As the hinges were cut, the door fell to the ground.

"And… another tunnel!" O'Neill said. "I knew that we should've picked door number tree!"

"There was only one door," Entrapta said. "And another coming up."

"Sorry, Jack's making references to another TV show," Daniel said.

"Oh."

"Just trying to lighten the mood before Indiana Daniel grinds his teeth down with worry," O'Neill claimed. "And… another door!"

“I just told you that,” Entrapta said.

“Yes, you did. Same setup as before?”

“Yes.”

More hinges were cut. But this time, they had to cut the welded parts of the ‘lock’ as well.

The tunnel behind it opened into a large room. A room with walls filled with holes. And in the holes…

“That’s the graveyard. There must be… two dozen graves,” Daniel whispered.

“And full of Jaffa,” O’Neill said. “But one is different.” He moved the bot forward to an empty hole.

“That must have been meant for the Jaffa whose body we found in the ruins,” Daniel said. “But… where’s the staff weapon they used to seal this grave?”

“And what’s in the third grave from the right?” Entrapta asked. “It’s denser than a corpse.”

“Looks like a corpse,” O’Neill said.

“It’s behind the body.”

Catra didn’t wince when O’Neill dragged the dead Jaffa out of the niche and dumped the body on the floor. The sight of a skeleton covered with leathery skin falling apart as it hit the stone was rather gruesome, but it was just a thousand-year-old corpse - she’d seen far worse in the war.

“It looks like… A cube,” O’Neill said. “A fancy one.”

Catra narrowed her eyes. The cube looked familiar - half the size of a head. “Where have I seen this before?” She muttered. Then she remembered. “I saw one in Horde Prime’s flagship.”

“Oh.” Carter leaned forward. “It doesn’t look like the other examples of his technology that we’ve seen.”

Catra shook her head. “It wasn’t. It was a trophy.”

It looked like Adora’s theory that this belonged to an unknown species destroyed by Horde Prime was correct.

Yeah, losing that could have been bad.

*****

“So… what are we looking at?” Jack O’Neill asked as Carter and Entrapta bent over the cube now resting on a table. They had barely waited for the drone he piloted to put it down in the shuttle before grabbing it.

“We don’t know yet, Sir,” Carter replied. “But it’s not a battery.”

“It has connectors for power lines - not a standard format, though - but no power source or storage inside,” Entrapta added, staring at her scanner. “And the crystal formations inside do look somewhat familiar.”

“Our current theory is that it is a data storage device,” Carter said.

Data was good. “Great.” Jack smiled. “So, what’s on it?”

Both of the women looked at him with frowns on their faces.

“We don’t know yet, sir.” Carter didn’t roll her eyes, but he could tell she wanted to. “This is an alien device, with a different computer technology, architecture and programming language. We haven’t encountered this technology before. Just building an adapter so we can power it up will take a while. Then we have to find a way to read the data and may have to decrypt it.”

“So… tomorrow at the latest?” Jack joked with a grin.

Carter gave him that 'You know better than that, Sir' look of hers, but Entrapta seemed to take him seriously.

"We can't say yet. It depends on how different the technology is. The basic principles for crystal-based data storage are the same, or should be, but the data format and encryption…" The princess shrugged. "It's hard to say how long this will take. If the encryption is sufficiently advanced, we might not be able to crack it at all!" she added with a smile. "Wouldn't that be interesting?"

"Can't you check with the fleet for information?" Daniel asked. He was staring at the cube like… Well, like an archaeologist at a new site. This was a data cube from a - probably - lost civilisation. Pretty much a holy grail for him.

"We can and did, but they have no data about this. Horde Prime didn't share whatever he knew about this cube," Entrapta said.

"If he even knew anything about it, except for which species had built it," Catra said with a scowl. "He wanted trophies, not data."

"That would've been a waste!" Entrapta protested.

Jack refrained from pointing out that a warlord who rendered entire species extinct wouldn't care about waste. Instead, he nodded at the two women and joined the others in the back. Clapping his hands, he asked: "So, while Carter and Entrapta are busy, who's up for another excursion?"

"Oh?" Adora perked up.

"There are potentially two dozen Goa'uld on this planet," Jack said. None of the corpses in the tomb had the remains of larvae in them. "We need to scan the perimeter so we can be sure that they aren't trying to sneak on board of the wreck - or on the shuttle."

Melog the cat growled, and Catra shook her head. "There's no Goa'uld nearby."

“So the cat said,” Jack replied, nodding. “But that still leaves a whole planet where they could be hiding.”

“We can scan the Goa’uld corpse,” Entrapta cut in - when had she joined them? - “and check the concentration of Naquadah in its blood. If it’s higher than it should be, the Goa’uld probably ate his kin.”

Adora grimaced.

Jack didn’t. That was how the Goa’uld were. And it was a clever way to find out if there should be more of them. “Let’s do that.”

“Good! I need new scans of Teal’c’s larva first, to check if the concentration decays over time,” Entrapta said.

“It should not,” Teal’c said.

“We’ll see!” Entrapta was already waving her scanner at him. “Then we need to find out how efficient the digestive system of a Goa’uld is when it comes to absorbing Naquadah from ingested larvae - oh, I need to scan the animal they had taken over, too! Too bad they don’t show up on global scans since the concentration needed for that would probably be toxic, but short-range, we should be able to detect them with the right calibration - once we know the parameters we need.”

Right. Jack nodded with a firm expression. This seemed to become a little more involved than he had thought. But as long as it worked… It would delay decrypting the data cube, but the thing wasn’t time-critical; it had been buried under a hill for a thousand years, after all.

While Entrapta and Carer did their scanning thing, Jack stretched. “So, who wants to grab something to eat? Just don’t eat the dead snake; we still need to scan it.”

Adora and Daniel frowned at him for the joke, but Catra snorted. Teal’c, of course, didn’t react at all. In other words: just as expected.

They went to the kitchen of the shuttle, and Jack grabbed a few pre-packed meals. "Roasted probably beef OK?" The Etherians had cows, but Jack didn't know if they had used beef for this meal.

"Of course," Adora said.

Jack looked at the others. Adora would eat rations without complaints.

"Yeah," Catra said. Teal'c nodded. Daniel blinked. "Uh… what else is available?"

Jack handed him the meals. Then, while Daniel looked them over, he sat down at the table.

"Thank you again for saving my life," he told Adora.

She fidgeted. "Oh, it was… I mean, I can heal, so I did. I would have done it for anyone."

"Just say 'you're welcome', dummy!" Catra shook her head.

Adora pouted at her.

Jack suppressed a sigh. While it was refreshing to meet someone as powerful as Adora - a real magical princess - without any arrogance, she was overdoing the humble bit. And Jack had the feeling that she wasn't faking it at all.

Which wasn't a good thing. Not at all.

*****

Adora frowned at her girlfriend. She hadn't saved Jack's life to be thanked - she had saved him because that's what you did when a friend was in danger. Or anyone else was in danger. She was She-Ra; she had a duty to help people.

Catra stuck out her tongue at Adora in return before starting on her meal - which was a grilled fish, of course. Her lover really loved fish in all forms. As did Melog. It was probably a cat thing.

"So, what do we do about the Goa'uld?" Adora asked to get things back on more familiar tracks. "Once we know if there are more around, that is."

Jack shrugged. "Try to capture them if possible. Kill them if not."

That sounded… "We don't know if they are hostile," Adora said. "We know the one Catra killed was because he attacked us. But no one else attacked us."

"So far," Catra said as she refilled her glass.

"They're snakes," Jack said.

"But they can't hurt anyone on this planet," Adora pointed out.

"Except for the animals," Daniel said.

Adora frowned at him. "That's not a reason to hunt them down."

"PETA would disagree," Jack said, chuckling.

"PETA?" Adora cocked her head.

"An animal rights activist organisation," Daniel explained. "They are considered to be a little extremist."

"Animal rights?" Catra asked.

"In many countries on Earth, it's illegal to treat animals cruelly," Daniel replied. "And such organisations lobby for stricter laws when it comes to keeping animals."

Adora hated to parrot Daniel, but… "Stricter laws?"

"Ah." He smiled at her and pushed his glasses up his nose. "There are laws regulating how you have to treat your animals - a

minimal standard, both for pets and livestock, although with different rules. Such as minimal care, space in the pen, and so on."

"Ah." That made sense.

"Such organisations also take care of stray animals and work to protect the wildlife." Daniel nodded. "They organise boycotts of firms who destroy the habits of wildlife or treat their livestock cruelly."

Adora nodded. That sounded nice. Although…

"You need such laws and activism?" Catra asked. "How do you treat animals?"

The way Daniel winced wasn't a good sign, Adora thought.

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"So, many of the animals you eat are kept in stables and never let outside." Adora slowly nodded as she grabbed her empty plate and put it into the dishwasher or whatever Entrapta had built. It cleaned dishes. Or destroyed them and made new ones - Adora wasn't quite sure.

"Many, yes. Not all." Daniel followed her example as she sat down again.

"So?" Catra shook her head. "If you're going to eat them anyway…" She shrugged and pushed her own plate away.

Adora sighed and grabbed it as well, handing it over to Daniel.

"Animal rights activists think that animals should live as happily as possible and as close to nature as possible," he said as he grabbed Jack's plate.

"Nature's brutal," Jack said. "And most farm animals couldn't survive in the wild."

“But they could survive outside a stable,” Daniel replied, sitting down again. “As we’ve also seen on Etheria.”

Adora didn’t want to be dragged into that discussion. She didn’t know enough about animals to have a definite opinion. “And you spoil your pets!” she said to change the subject.

“Oh, yes.” Jack chuckled. “Many pets are treated better than humans.”

“Well, that’s not really impressive,” Catra commented.

Adora nodded. “You already told us that in some places, humans are treated really badly.”

“Ah.” Jack looked at a loss for words for a moment.

Daniel pushed his glasses up his nose with one finger. “Technically correct. But Jack was thinking about pets that are treated better than humans in the same place - roughly speaking.”

Now that was… how could you treat an animal better than a person? Outside of war, of course, where you had to fight the person and not the animal. Or when it came to criminals. But Adora was sure that Daniel wasn’t talking about those cases.

“Whatever,” Catra spoke up after finishing her drink. “Animals are animals. Some of them are monsters. I don’t really care for any animal that tries to attack me. The question is: Can we spend the time hunting down Goa’uld stuck on this planet? And can we afford to let them on the planet?”

“Well, they have had a thousand years and didn’t develop the resources to get off the planet, much less be a threat to a space-based civilisation,” Daniel replied. “If they are still alive, that is. So, I don’t really think we need to hunt them down.”

“Yes,” Adora agreed.

“Unless we find them nearby. A bunch of prisoners would be useful,” Catra added as she leaned back on her seat until she was all but slipping off it.

Adora rolled her eyes and reached over to poke her belly.

Catra eeped and snapped back into a sitting position. “Hey!”

“You were being rude,” Adora told her.

“I wasn’t!”

“Sure you were. Next thing, you’re napping in their bed.”

“I wouldn’t do that! I only nap in our bed. Or on the couch. Or the bench in the garden.”

“And the planning table,” Adora reminded her.

“That was such a boring briefing that even Glimmer nodded off!”

Adora chuckled at the memory. “Yes, she did.”

Catra suddenly grinned, then slid off her seat and into Adora’s lap before she could react, snuggling up to her. “I’m going to take a nap right here,” she whispered into Adora’s ear.

“Ah…” Adora trailed off. How should she react to that? She wanted to kiss - or tickle - her, but that would be rude as well, wouldn’t it?

Fortunately, Entrapta picked that moment to return from the hold. “We’ve analysed the remains!”

Adora straightened, prompting a noise of protest from Catra. “Yes?”

“Come to the hold; we’ll show you!”

*****

“Here!”

Samantha Carter looked up as Entrapta led the others into their makeshift laboratory. The princess was smiling as she pointed at the tank where the dissected Goa'uld was floating.

"If we had had such a tank back in school," the Colonel commented at once, "biology would have been much more interesting."

Sam chuckled at the joke. Once. "We've finished the autopsy and analysis," she told him. "The concentration of Naquadah in the corpse was high enough to indicate that the Goa'uld had consumed at least a dozen larvae. That is under the assumption that their base levels were the same for regular Goa'uld larvae at the start."

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "So, we're missing about a dozen Goa'uld."

"Or one Goa'uld who consumed them," Catra said. "Or they died in the wilderness and were eaten by animals."

Entrapta nodded again. "Exactly! Or another combination, like one who consumed half a dozen or so and the others were eaten by predators."

"Great." The Colonel didn't like it. "And none of them are near."

"Many Goa'uld would, faced with a potentially lethal battle, spread out to avoid conflict," Teal'c said.

"And they have an entire planet and all its animals to do so." The Colonel shook his head.

"Searching an entire planet with, well, short-range sensors and…" Daniel looked embarrassed. "...and people who can sense them sounds a little…" He trailed off.

"Yes," the Colonel agreed. "I think that would take a lot of time."

“Well, covering the entire surface of the planet - and assuming no Goa’uld took a marine animal or cave dwellers as a host - would take us…” Entrapta started pushing buttons on her main tool. “We’d be here for weeks with an optimal search grid and breaks and some redundancy. That depends on how sensitive you are to their presence at higher travel speeds. We might have to adjust that, should we have to fly more slowly.”

And they didn’t have weeks.

“So, let’s call in the fleet to pack up the Al’Kesh and leave.” The Colonel looked around. “Unless you disagree?”

Catra looked like she wanted to disagree out of principle, but Adora nodded. “Yes, I think that’s a good idea.”

“Let’s do it then. And Carter and Entrapta can go back to cracking the data cube.”

“Oh, no!!” Entrapta replied. “We’re saving that as a last resort. We’re trying less destructive methods first.”

“Ah, good.” The Colonel nodded, but Sam saw him wince for a moment - he still hadn’t adjusted to Entrapta’s… to Entrapta. Well, unlike Sam, he hadn’t had much interaction with some of the more eccentric scientists in her field. Or Daniel’s.

Catra was smirking again. “So… we’re done then. I’m going to take a nap.” She stretched her arms over her head and yawned.

“Catra!”

“What? I’m no good at cracking encryption.”

“Still! We’re on a mission.”

“We’re on a part of the mission where we have to wait and do nothing until the fleet arrives. Might as well rest. Or what else do you suggest we should do?”

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again, blushing slightly, before she shook her head. “We need to be ready if anything happens.”

“Oh, I’ll be ready for anything,” Catra said as she sauntered out of the hold.

“Really!” Adora smiled at them - Sam could tell it was forced - and followed her girlfriend.

“Oh for…” The Colonel shook his head.

“Jack?” Daniel looked confused. “Is something wrong?”

“Nothing,” the Colonel replied. He was still looking at the door, though, not at Daniel - or Sam. And when he turned back to face them, Sam looked away.

“So, let’s continue not-cracking the cube!” Entrapta said.

As Sam turned back to the cube - they still had to build an interface that would connect to the alien port - the others filed out of the hold as well.

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Samantha Carter rubbed her neck and temples when she left the hold. They had managed to connect the data cube to a computer, but that had been all they had managed to achieve - the data contained inside it remained inaccessible. They were still trying to find a way to actually access the memory crystals - they couldn’t even tell if the data was encrypted or if the alien file transfer protocols and system architecture were just incompatible.

Entrapta hadn’t lost any of her enthusiasm, though - she seemed to thrive when faced with such a challenge. Well, Sam had to admit that she wasn’t really getting frustrated either. It just felt bad to let the others down. The Colonel had been joking about them being finished in a day, but she knew he had expected more results from her.

On the way to the bridge, she grabbed a sandwich from the fridge - she was getting a little bit hungry, and it would prevent more remarks about taking care of herself. She could do that perfectly fine, after all, and sometimes, you had to skip meals to push on.

"Ah, Carter!" The Colonel turned to face her. "You're just in time to watch our zealous fleet pick up an Al'Kesh."

Sam turned her head towards the windows on the right of the ship. Indeed, there was a frigate hovering above the Goa'uld bomber.

"They emptied their hangar of fighters and cut out the decks inside," the Colonel explained as the bomber slowly was drawn into the frigate by a tractor beam.

"Adora just had to ask," Catra commented, sitting in one of the seats.

Adora sighed. "I didn't see a better way to salvage the ship. There's enough space in other frigates for the fighters. And we can repair the hangar once we can dump the al-Kesh somewhere."

Like Earth. Having an Al'Kesh to study and possibly copy would be great. Not as impressive as a mothership with big honking space guns, as the Colonel would say, but with a working faster-than-light craft, Stargate Command would gain a lot more options for missions.

On the other hand, compared to the fleet of frigates she was currently observing, it didn't look very impressive.

"How standards shift," she whispered to herself.

*****

In Orbit above PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"No, we're not going to bombard the planet to kill off any hypothetical Goa'uld hiding amongst the local animals!"

Catra fought the urge to laugh as she listened to Adora talk to Priest - or at Priest - on Darla's bridge. The situation was funny, but she knew not many would agree with her.

"But Your Divine Highness! We cannot leave an enemy behind!" Priest protested. "And you stated that we cannot take the time to search the entire planet since we don't have enough scanners to detect Naquadah. So, the obvious solution is a thorough orbital bombardment of the entire planetary surface. Without potential hosts, the Goa'uld will die."

"So will the planet," Adora said.

"Yes, Your Divine Highness." Priest nodded. He looked confused.

Adora's forehead sported a twitching vein now. "We don't destroy planets any more," Adora said through clenched teeth.

"But I thought we wouldn't destroy inhabited planets any more. There is no intelligent life on this planet except for your enemies, Your Divine Highness."

"It's a planet!" Adora blurted out. "We're not going to destroy a planet just to kill a few Goa'uld stuck on it without any way to get off!"

"We don't know for certain that they don't have the means. Should an enemy ship arrive, they could easily be rescued, Your Divine Highness," Priest retorted.

"They've been marooned on the planet for a thousand years!" Adora told him.

"But that is no assurance that the current state of affairs will continue, Your Divine Highness," Priest said. "In fact, if we create a supply route through this sector and engage in warfare against the System Lords, they are bound to send in ships to scout and raid our lines, which means that this system could end up becoming a staging ground. Imagine the threat that such spies would pose to us then!"

“Their intel is a thousand years out of date,” Adora replied. “We’re not going to destroy a planet like this, and that is final!”

“As you command, Your Divine Highness.” Priest bowed, and the transmission ended.

Adora sagged and closed her eyes. Catra stepped up and rubbed her back.

“I’m just… What’s wrong with them? Destroying a planet to kill a few Goa’uld? Who might not even be alive?” Adora shook her head.

“They’re not used to caring about… well, anyone except…” Catra trailed off. She knew the feeling. Knew it too well.

“Anyone except me. Their replacement Prime,” Adora said.

Catra hissed in response, then slugged Adora’s upper arm. “Don’t talk like that! This is completely different! You are completely different!”

“But they see me as their new leader!” Adora protested.

“So?” Catra forced herself to shrug. “So does most of Etheria. They see you as the new Angella.” She bit her lower lip at the guilt that filled her, remembering why the Queen had been lost. All her fault…

“I’m not a queen!”

“No, and neither are you a new Horde Prime. You’re She-Ra. And a dummy.” Catra told her. Her smile was a little lopsided and toothy.

But Adora didn’t seem to notice or mind. She started to smile as well, then sighed. “I guess. But it’s… tiring. Dealing with Priest and… I’m not a goddess!”

“No, you aren’t.” How often had she told that Adora so far? Well, Catra would keep telling it until Adora stopped being bothered by Priest.

“But… Priest and his followers need to learn that… that they can’t just act as if I were Horde Prime. We won’t destroy entire planets!” Adora raised her chin slightly.

Catra nodded, though she was not as convinced. Some targets might be worth destroying a planet for. Not that she would say that out loud. Not after the Heart of Etheria almost broke Adora. “You’ve got a few more weeks to teach that to Priest,” she said. “Before we reach Earth.”

Adora sagged again and sighed. “Don’t remind me. What will the Earth people think of us once they meet Priest? What will they think of me, being worshipped as a goddess when they are fighting the Goa’uld who do the same?”

Oh for…! Catra growled. “They’ll do the same as SG-1 does: Nothing. They know the difference. They know you don’t want to be worshipped.” With a grin, Catra added: “Well, not like Priest does.”

Adora blushed heavily. “Catra!”

Catra grinned in response and leaned forward to lick Adora’s cheek. “Hm?” She ran a hand over Adora’s hair - which really would look much better without the poof - and down her back.

Adora took a deep breath but didn’t protest or pull away. “Catra…”

“Hm?” Catra lightly bit her ear.

“We’re on the bridge,” Adora hissed.

“And we’re alone.” Everyone else was on the frigate in front of them, checking out the Al-Kesh and showing the clones what not to touch. Even Melog had gone, in case they had a stowaway snake.

"But… anyone can look through the windows!" Adora said, pointing at the frigate.

"So? I'm just doing my duty as your consort," Catra replied, then licked Adora's cheek again.

Further protests from her dummy lover she stifled with a kiss.

It was high time that they finally used the captain's chair for something more entertaining than piloting the ship.

*****

In Orbit above PK-327, July 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill wasn't jealous. Or envious. Not at all. He didn't have a crush on either Adora or Catra. Adora was a very attractive woman, but she was half his age, tops. And a magical girl. And Catra was a catwoman, and not the leather catsuit kind, but the kind with real fur. And also half his age.

Nor was he planning to have sex in his free time during this mission. Or any mission. He wouldn't want a repeat of his close brush with dying of old age due to Goa'uld experiments, and he had no partner in mind anyway. Not any who would be available.

So, his annoyance at the fact that Adora and Catra had done the naughty on their ship's bridge while everyone else was checking out the Al'Kesh had nothing to do with either jealousy or envy. It was merely his sense of professionalism that was hurt. That, and that he hadn't gotten to sit in the captain's chair before it was used as a loveseat.

"So," Catra asked, brushing a stray lock of wet hair out of her face - both had showered, at least - "What's the final verdict on the bomber?"

Jack looked at his SIC. "Carter?"

“We haven’t completed our assessment yet,” Carter replied at once. “But, so far, we have found no damage that wouldn’t be able to be fixed with sufficient effort at Stargate Command.”

“Or in one of Third Fleet’s mobile shipyards,” Catra said, “in the fleet train.”

“Yes.” Carter nodded. She hid her reaction well, but Jack knew her - she would prefer to go over the ship herself. If the clones repaired it, Stargate Command wouldn’t get any experience in maintaining and repairing spaceships. And they needed that if they ever wanted to stop depending on their allies for ships.

“Yeah,” he said, “let’s see what we can do with it, first, before we hand it over to the fleet. It’s not as if we have a pressing need for an additional ship.” They had an entire fleet with them, after all.

“It would be faster, though,” Adora said - her hair was also wet, but her poof was, somehow, unaffected. “Wouldn’t you want a fully functional ship?”

Was that a veiled hint that Stargate Command would get the Al’Kesh? No, Adora wasn’t the type to be so subtle. It probably meant that she had never planned to lay claim to the ship herself.

“If we repair it, we can also add electronics and communication gear that will allow us to operate it in close cooperation with other forces of Earth,” Carter said.

“Ah.” Adora nodded. “That makes sense.”

“You can tinker with the wreck to your heart’s content, then,” Catra added with a smirk.

“We will,” Jack replied. The geeks back home would be overjoyed. Hell, Carter would love it. And if they weren’t about to arrive with a fleet in tow, the brass would be ecstatic about the opportunity to get a spaceship. As things were, the whole fleet of zealots thing would overshadow everything else.

"And I'll help!" Entrapta said. "This is so interesting - it's a completely different design philosophy compared to either the Horde or the First Ones!"

A pretty useless design philosophy, in Jack's opinion. When they started restoring the Al'Kesh, he'd make some suggestions. Some quite strong suggestions. Gun turrets that covered all sides, at the very least - Stargate Command didn't have fighters to escort the Al'Kesh. Which would need a name of her own, too. He snorted at the realisation that the geeks would push for 'Enterprise'. Although it was pretty much the best name for Earth's first spaceship, even if it was the name of a Navy ship.

"I am looking forward to helping as well," Bow added with a smile. "I've got some experience with repairing a thousand-year-old ship."

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "This will be fun!"

"Yes," Glimmer said, and she sounded like one of Jack's old superior officers when faced with one of his more colourful reports. "So, we're ready to continue our trip. But we need to decide what we do about the potential Goa'uld holdouts."

"Blow up the ruins and tombs from orbit," Catra said at once.

"Catra!" Adora protested.

"What? It's just a small area. Leave a crater, and people won't be stumbling around in ruins and getting caught by Goa'uld." Catra grinned. "Or, better write a warning into the crater with the cannons!"

Jack blinked. That would… He chuckled. "That would actually work."

"It would also reveal our presence," Carter pointed out. "Anyone who examines the remains will be able to tie them to Horde weapons."

“But there are a lot of Horde ships around,” Catra retorted. “Or we can build a bomb ourselves and use the Al’Kesh’s weapons to write the warning.”

That would be very ironic. Jack nodded in approval. “Let’s do that!”

“Yes! Let’s build a bomb!”

Entrapta’s enthusiastic agreement made Jack have second thoughts about this idea.

But it was too late - everyone else was agreeing as well.

Damn.

Well, at least they’d get to see a big explosion and foil whatever plans the Goa’uld on the ground, if there were any, might have. And that was a victory in Jack’s book.

*****

The Inconvenient Truth

Hyperspace, On the Way to Earth, July 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

4th: No orbital bombardments without clearance by the commander in chief.

Sitting at the table in the mess, Adora nodded at the screen of her pad. That was a very important rule. Perhaps she should place it at a more prominent spot? But 'protect innocent sentient life forms' was also very important. As was 'collateral damage should be avoided whenever possible'. Hm…

"That should be 'without clearance by Adora or whoever she promoted to commander in chief'," someone whispered into her ear - her breath tickled Adora's skin.

Adora gasped. "Catra!" She hadn't noticed her lover sneaking up on her.

"Hm?" Catra chuckled as she withdrew. "I'm just helping. I did write a lot of orders, you know."

"Yes. But this is a special case," Adora said. "I need a list of rules that will keep Third Fleet from blowing up planets to kill a single Goa'uld."

"Then you want the orders to be very clear," Catra said.

"No Auftragstaktik," Jack added as he entered and grabbed a bottle of water from the fridge.

"Auftragstaktik?" Adora frowned. What did that mean?

"That's where you tell your men what you need to be done, but not how they should do it," he explained.

"Oh."

Catra nodded. “Yes, you really don’t want to do that with Priest.”

Adora frowned at her. She knew that very well, thank you very much.

“Oh, yes. If you asked him to get some milk from the supermarket, he probably would conquer the country in the name of you,” Jack added with a grin.

Adora frowned at him as well. “I am aware of that. That’s why I am going to give him precise orders.”

Catra shrugged. “Just be ready to add more orders - you’ll never cover everything that can go wrong.”

“Yes.” Daniel peered inside the mess, then stepped inside. Had Adora missed a meeting notice or something? “Like the list of things Jack isn’t allowed to do any more.”

“There’s no such list, and if there were any, it would cover the entire team,” Jack protested.

“Your team, your responsibility,” Daniel shot back. “Oh, pudding!”

“Oh? Tell us more!” Catra leaned across the table and beamed at Daniel.

“That’s classified,” Jack said.

“You playing on your Game Boy during briefings is classified?” Daniel grinned.

“I never got caught! and I only did it during the boring parts!”

“What’s a ‘Game Boy’?” Catra asked.

“Oh. That’s a portable gaming console,” Daniel explained. Which didn’t explain anything.

“You play video games on it,” Jack added. Adora looked at him, and he went on: “Video games are… games you play on a

computer."

Daniel shook his head. "Allow me. Video games are electronic games that you play…"

*****

"...and that's why they are called video games. They come in a very wide range of genres and are very popular amongst children, teenagers and some adults," Daniel finished.

"Ah." Adora looked at Catra. She wasn't entirely sure, but while Catra nodded as if the explanation had actually explained everything, Adora thought her lover was just faking.

"Video games are quite popular amongst adults as well," Jack said with a slight pout.

"You would say that, Jack."

"Daniel…"

Ador cleared her throat. "Anyway, I was working on my list." It would be rude to send them out, but she needed some peace and quiet to work on that. And her and Catra's cabin definitely wouldn't be suitable, what with Catra in a playful mood.

"Right, your list!" Jack nodded.

"Yes," Daniel nodded as well. "Your commandments. I am looking forward to seeing how Priest and his church will interpret them. It should be a fascinating study of how holy scripture came to be."

"What?" Adora stared at him.

"Daniel wants to see how your orders will be turned in holy commandments," Jack said. "Word of God - or, in this case, word of the Goddess."

Adora closed her mouth. That wasn't what she wanted! Not at all! "But…"

"I bet Priest will have the orders burned into a golden plate and fixed on the bridge of every ship," Catra interrupted her. "Do you think we can make them rhyme so they can sing the lines?"

Her lover was joking - she had to be! - but Adora could see Priest doing that. She shook her head until her ponytail hit her face. Her orders, enshrined like that? Her friends would never let her forget it. "Anything but that!"

"The alternative would be no lasting restrictions," Daniel pointed out. "Religious commandments were often a restraining influence in Earth's past."

"The point is, Daniel, that Adora doesn't want to found a religion," Jack told him.

"I think it's clear that the religion already exists, Jack. So, the best solution would be to use the opportunity, rather than struggling futilely to turn back time," Daniel retorted.

Adora was about to tell them not to talk about her as if she wasn't present when Catra spoke up in that fake innocent tone of hers: "Well, it'll be amusing to see Priest trying to convert Earth to the worship of Adora."

The wide-eyed glance Jack and Daniel exchanged in return wasn't helping Adora's mood in the slightest.

*****

Warhead separation complete. Five seconds to impact. Four. Three. Two. One.

On the screen, the ruins and the hill vanished in a fireball each. Samantha Carter watched as the multiple angles blanked out in rapid succession until only the orbital view remained, showing two converging mushroom clouds.

“It’s a beautiful sight, isn’t it?” Entrapta commented. “The bombs performed as calculated!”

Sam slowly nodded. She wasn’t quite as enthusiastic about the bombs they had built as Entrapta was, but a part of her was proud that they had managed to rig a warhead that struck both sites at the same time with Naqadah-enhanced bombs in such a short time. But that was just the technical aspect. With this as proof of concept, the genie was out of the bottle - now such bombs would be on the table for other situations as well. Situations where the targets weren’t just ruins devoid of intelligent life.

On the screen, the cloud started to dissipate - faster than in real life; Entrapta had sped up the recording - and revealed two huge craters.

“Now comes my favourite part!” Entrapta said as a Horde frigate descended above the craters. “Yes!” she all but squealed when two lances of red light appeared under the frigate, stabbing down into the crater. The screen split again, showing the lasers burning into the glassed surface below. Writing.

Potential Goa’uld on the planet. Beware.

In Goa’uld - as much as Daniel hated it, it was the lingua franca of a big part of the galaxy. Most people in the sector would be able to read it. It would also tell Goa’uld that someone hostile had destroyed the ruins, but that couldn’t be avoided. And the paranoid System Lords might well suspect one of their own trying to throw off suspicion - that was why they had used Goa’uld weapons, after all.

Not that the odds that it would matter were great anyway - sooner or later, Sam’s money was on sooner, the Alliance would engage in open warfare with the Goa’uld. With help from Earth, unless something went very wrong when they reached home.

In any case, at that point, the Goa'uld would know who they were facing, and any intel potential Goa'uld left on the planet might provide would be even more outdated than it already was.

"You must really love this," Entrapta said. "You've been watching it five times so far."

Sam blinked and realised that the recording had ended. "I was looking for more data," she lied. Well, it wasn't a complete lie - there was a chance that she had missed something the four other times she had watched the recording.

"Oh! Did you discover something?"

"No." Sam shook her head. She hadn't found anything new. And, maybe, it was time to stop watching what she had wrought and get back to working on the alien data cube. They had still a few weeks until they reached Earth, and if they encountered a Stargate on the way, Sam wouldn't be able to work on the cube until the fleet reached Earth. Not even then, she knew - she would likely be too busy with other work, mainly the Al'kesh repairs. And briefing various generals and politicians.

She wasn't looking forward to that. She wouldn't go as far as to call it a waste of time, as the Colonel did, but she could do much more important work than telling people who were as likely to ignore her as to heed her words things they could read up in her reports. Which she had to update with the latest data, actually.

But that could wait until the evening. "Let's tackle the data cube again," she said. "I think we haven't tried base-13 yet, did we?" They hadn't; Sam had checked.

"Oh, yes. I mean, no, we haven't!" Entrapta skipped over to the table where the cube was waiting for them. "Let's try this out!"

"Yes." Sam smiled - it was great to work with an enthusiastic partner.

"I'll call Hordak, too! He's had a few interesting ideas as well!"

Sam kept smiling with a bit of effort. She wasn't nearly as fond of Hordak as she was of Entrapta. The man - the alien - was a genius, no doubt about it. But he was also a former warlord with alien morals, and Sam wasn't entirely sure that he had changed enough not to slide back into old habits, should he deem it necessary. And while she had been told that Entrapta's influence had changed him, she knew that Hordak's influence would have changed Entrapta as well. And would continue to do so.

Well, Sam could exert some influence as well. If Hordak wanted to get a pet scientist to unleash monstrous weapons on defenceless civilians, he wouldn't get his way if Sam had anything to say about it.

"You've finished the documentation, then."

"Yes!" Entrapta said, nodding as she went to Hordak, who stood in the door. "And we're ready to continue with the data cube!"

Had he been listening until this moment? Or was this just coincidence? Sam nodded at him. Politely. "Yes."

"Enhancing explosives with Naquadah will facilitate further offensive operations," Hordak said. "Defending assets against attacks with such bombs will be more difficult, though."

That was obvious, of course. On Earth, it had led to a somewhat stable peace between nuclear powers thanks to the threat of mutually assured destruction. She doubted that they could or should achieve the same with the Goa'uld.

But the way the former warlord talked about assets and operations… Sam didn't like that.

*****

Hyperspace, On the Way to Earth, July 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Catra yawned as she leaned back in her seat on the bridge of Darla. Standing watch was as boring as ever. As expected - she had spent time in space before, after all, and unless you were trying to fool Horde Prime, running for your life, or exploring some ancient ruins, it was generally very dull. Especially without Adora or anyone else to talk to because it was the night shift. Night watch.

Everyone else was asleep. Unless Entrapta or Carter had sneaked into the hold to tinker with the cube again. She checked the display on her right - no, the hold was empty of life signatures. Unless someone had fiddled with the ship's internal sensors, of course. Which… wasn't too implausible, actually.

Well, she hadn't anything better to do, so she might as well check personally. And grab a drink from the kitchen. Or kitchenette, as O'Neill called it.

She got up and walked out of the bridge, then frowned - the light was on in the kitchen area. And - her ears twitched - someone was heating tea. If Entrapta had actually sneaked out… "Hey!"

It wasn't Entrapta. She saw Daniel, gasping, standing next to the pot of boiling water. "What are you doing here?" she asked.

"Making tea?" He pointed at the kettle.

She rolled her eyes. "I meant, why aren't you sleeping?"

To his credit, he didn't make a stupid joke about her having to ask what she meant in the first place but shrugged. "I got caught translating some of the books."

They had a library on board? That was news to her. Not that she'd admit it. "What book are you reading?"

"It's actually one of Bow's history books," he told her.

Ah. So, he was talking about Bow's books. Well, history books were pretty harmless. If it had been Entrapta's diary or notes of

bot construction… She shrugged. “Sounds pretty boring.”

“It’s actually fascinating how Etheria’s culture evolved over a thousand years,” he said. “The way magic powers shaped history on your planet…”

“Yeah, yeah, magic princesses rule,” she cut him off and grabbed a cup of her own.

“That’s a very simplified view,” he said with a slight pout.

“But a correct one. In the Horde, we were taught that the princesses were evil, you know?” she said as she dropped some leaves in a streamer. “That they were fighting us because we didn’t have princesses.”

“Well, on Earth, when France overthrew their monarchy, the other monarchies banded together to fight the new government. They didn’t declare war merely because of the revolution, there were many other reasons, but it was a contributing factor,” Daniel told her. “Executing the king and queen did help escalate the situation as well, of course.”

“They didn’t fight us because we had overthrown our princess,” Catra retorted. Well, in as much as Scorpia was their princess. “They fought us because we invaded them and tried to conquer them.” They had actually conquered quite a bit of Etheria under her leadership.

“Of course.” He nodded. “I’m just pointing out possible parallels to the history of Earth.”

“And potential trouble,” she added.

He winced, then took a sip from his steaming cup and winced even more. “Yes, that too.”

Catra jumped slightly to sit on the counter, blowing on her cup. “So, how bad will it be?” Daniel was the most honest of SG-1, she

knew that. And without his friends around, he should be likely to let slip something.

He looked puzzled for a moment. “When we arrive on Earth?”

“Yes. Magic, princesses, fanatical clones with a space fleet…” She took a sip from her own cup. A little too hot, but tolerable.

“Well…” He grimaced. “It will be a shock to find out that aliens are real.”

“That’s obvious.” They had gone over that already. “But afterwards, when the shock’s faded, and we’re talking alliance.”

“Ah.” He pursed his lips. “It’s hard to say. Historically, people tend to be pragmatic when they are faced with a common enemy. Even ideological enemies.”

That sounded good. “So, you’re going to play one happy, united front and ignore all the differences?”

“That would be best for the war, wouldn’t it?” He blew on his cup again, then took a swallow, sighing with his eyes closed. The man liked the tea, even though he claimed that he preferred coffee - but they had run out of the bitter brew.

“Probably.” She shrugged again. “In my experience, ignoring differences isn’t a good idea. It can lead to losing a war.” She knew that from personal experience.

“Oh.” He took another swallow.

“So, what’s the worst problem we’ll face? Magic? Or Monarchies? Our gender?”

“That’s hard to say. Earth isn’t very homogenous, and even in our country, there are distinct groups with very different views and interests.” He smiled rather weakly.

“So, all of the above?” she asked with a wry grin.

He nodded, making a noncommittal noise, and hid his mouth behind his cup again.

"I see." She nodded as well.

Great. She would have to talk with the rest about this. Once they were awake, of course.

*****

Hyperspace, On the Way to Earth, July 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Another day, another empty system," Jack O'Neill commented as he stepped on the bridge of the Darla.

"We don't know if the system is actually empty, Sir," Carter told him, as he had expected.

Good to know that she hadn't been entirely lost to the alien data cube. Perhaps Jack shouldn't have joked about expecting her to crack the thing in one day - she seemed to have taken it as a challenge. Though, to be fair, there wasn't much else to do on the ship during this trip. Except for checking the Al'kesh, but since that was transported on a Horde frigate, she would have to leave the Darla for that - and Jack wasn't about to split up his team.

"Well, we'll soon know!" Entrapta piped up. "Dropping out of hyperspace in five… four… three… two… one!"

"Nothing in close range," Bow reported. "Long-range scanners… Contacts!"

Jack didn't jerk, but he leaned forward on his seat. "Have they seen us?"

"Not unless they have improved sensors," Bow replied.

Jack glanced at the side screen. The holographic display zoomed in on the system, past the outer planets, and came to a stop at

the second planet - a habitable world, it seemed. He counted a dozen ships in orbit, and they were… firing onto each other.

"It's a war zone," Daniel stated the obvious as one of the ships - blew up.

"Three Ha'taks, eight Al'kesh. Multiple Death Gliders," Bow reported.

"It's an invasion," Jack said. The three Ha'taks were working together, flying in formation with the Al'keshs. But the Death Gliders were dogfighting - and some were attacking the Al'kesh.

"And unless the defenders have reinforcements waiting for them, they have lost the battle," Teal'c stated.

"Yeah. A bunch of Death Gliders reenacting the Battle of Britain won't beat three Ha'taks," Jack said.

"Are they buying time for the ground forces to evacuate or disperse for guerilla campaign?" Catra asked.

"I can't tell from here," Entrapta said. "We need to get closer to find out."

"It depends on the System Lord who rules the planet," Teal'c said. "Some expect their Jaffa to fight to the death even when retreating would be advisable."

"What?" Adora frowned. "Why would they throw away their people?

"To keep the news of defeat from spreading amongst their troops," Daniel explained. "That might damage their claims of divinity."

"That's…" Adora shook her head.

"Monstrous," Glimmer spat. "And stupid. It means their enemy can undermine the trust of their people by spreading the news

themselves. That'll do more damage to the defender's reputation in the long run."

The princess was the commander of the Alliance, Jack reminded himself.

"And the soldiers will stop trusting any information from their superiors," Catra added.

"That's the Goa'uld for you - they're not very big on rational plans," Jack said.

"We can't underestimate them, Sir," Carter objected.

"I'm not saying their fools, just that they might not have the same view of what is rational and effective as we do," Jack replied.

"Hey, crazy plans can work very well - just ask Glimmer," Catra said with a smirk.

"What do you mean?" Glimmer asked with narrowed eyes just as Adora hissed: "Catra!"

"You know what I mean," Catra replied.

"My plan worked." Glimmer clenched her teeth. "It defeated the Horde."

"You were lucky. Very lucky." Catra bared her teeth.

"And it was all for nought since Horde Prime arrived in the moment of your triumph," Hordak added.

"Catra! Glimmer!" Adora snapped. "This is not the time!" She turned her head to glare at Hordak, who remained impassive.

Catra ducked her head with a pout, but Glimmer grew serious and nodded. "Yes. Sorry."

"Anyway!" Entrapta spoke up. "There's a significant amount of Naquadah on the planet, but I can't tell from here if there's a

Stargate."

"There could be mining operations," Carter speculated. "Although those should have better protection."

"Unless the main defenders were lured away - or they trusted secrecy," Jack said.

"So, who's invading whom here?" Adora asked.

"All those Goa'uld ships look the same," Jack said with a grin.

"They have an IFF transponder system," Carter added, "but they might not use distinctive codes for every mission."

"Well, if they are true to form, we just have to wait until the invaders win and broadcast the new rulers of the planet. It's a thing for them," Jack said. "Unless this is a black op, and they're only here to lay waste to the planet. Or a false flag operation."

"So, do we take our stealth ship in close? Try to find a gate while they are still busy shooting each other?" Daniel asked.

It was tempting. There would be chaos on the ground. A ship might slip through, and they might make their way to a stargate. Yet, they didn't know if there was a gate on the planet.

"We could blow all the Goa'uld ships up," Catra said. "The Third Fleet wouldn't have any trouble with them."

"Can they do that and prevent someone from sending out word about the attack?" Jack asked. He didn't want to lose operational surprise before they had a formal alliance with Etheria.

"Doubtful. We haven't found a way to reliably prevent FTL communications," Carter replied.

"Then we better not try to meddle," Jack said. If the Goa'uld killed each other, so much the better. "Unless they plan to massacre civilians." On the screen, another Al'kesh blew up, but then the

rest of them started to enter the atmosphere, and the Ha'taks spread out as well.

"There's a message broadcast in the clear," Bow said. A moment later, a Goa'uld voice filled the room.

"Your Death Gliders have been destroyed. Surrender to the divine Raiden!"

*****

"Raiden?" Adora asked. She hadn't heard about any Goa'uld with that name yet. Not that she'd remember, anyway.

"Raiden, also known as Raijin, is a Shinto god of lightning, thunder and storms," Daniel said. "And, obviously, a Goa'uld who has claimed the name. Or who has started the religion - since we lack records for most of the civilisations dating back to the time of the Goa'uld, it is often hard to determine whether the Goa'uld coopted existing mythological figures or created them." After a moment, he added: "Shinto is a religion centred on the Japanese Islands."

"Ah." That didn't actually tell Adora much, but it would be rude not to acknowledge Daniel's efforts.

"Raiden is a false god with a minor domain, in perpetual conflict with the vastly more powerful Yu," Teal'c said. "According to the star charts, however, we should not be in either of their territories."

"Well, for a vastly more powerful Goa'uld, those were pitiful defences," Catra commented with a frown. "Not really a big invasion fleet, either."

Adora agreed with her lover. The Third Fleet could wipe out all those ships easily. Of course, the Third Fleet wasn't stretched out protecting multiple worlds yet.

“Yu might be involved in another conflict with a stronger force and could have withdrawn his ships from this planet to protect more important systems,” Jack repeated his earlier speculation. “Or this world didn’t belong to Yu, but to another, weaker Goa’uld.”

Either possibility could be true. “What are they doing?” Adora asked.

“There’s been no answer from the people on the ground,” Bow said.

“That means bombing will start soon,” Jack said. “Goa’uld are testy about being ignored or refused.”

As he had predicted, the screen flared, and Bow reported the Al’kesh making bombing runs.

Catra stepped closer to the screen. “How precise are they? Can we tell from here?”

Bow grimaced. “I can’t tell what they’re aiming at - the scanner doesn’t show the planetary surface in detail.”

Adora made a mental note that they needed either better scanners or a way to get closer to a planet without being detected. It wouldn’t do to attack a planet without good intel or lose surprise by a recon mission being detected. The stealth system Entrapta and Sam had built for the shuttle might be the answer, but it hadn’t been tested against actual Goa’uld ships yet.

“The bombs they use have a rather high yield,” Entrapta said, frowning at the console next to her. “They do not seem to be very precise.”

Adora gripped the armrests of her chair. “Are they targeting civilians?” If they were…

“We can’t tell. We have to fly closer for that,” Bow said.

“If they detect us, operational surprise is lost,” Jack cautioned.

“But we might secure a working Stargate,” Sam pointed out.

“Let’s take the shuttle and fly closer. If they detect the shuttle, we’ll move the fleet in,” Adora said. “We can’t let them bomb civilians.”

“Alright,” Glimmer said. “But you’re staying here.” Adora was about to protest, but her friend went on: “Third Fleet won’t take well to you flying close to an enemy fleet in a simple shuttle.”

“They accepted our trip to the planet with the crashed Al-Kesh,” Adora said.

“PK-327,” Entrapta cut in.

“Yes, that.” Adora nodded.

“The system didn’t have a fleet in it,” Catra said.

Adora sighed. “Alright. But you’re staying here as well, Glimmer.”

Glimmer pouted at her, but Adora shrugged it off. If it was too dangerous for her, it was too dangerous for the Queen of Bright Moon.

“Let’s go, Bow,” Catra said - but she was looking at Adora.

After a moment, Adora nodded. Catra smiled and headed to the back, followed by Bow, Entrapta and SG-1.

And Adora closed her eyes and sighed. She hated staying back while her friends braved danger.

Glimmer didn’t say anything as she went and took over Bow position at the console.

“I hate this,” Adora muttered as she watched the shuttle leave on the side screen.

“Welcome to my life,” Glimmer replied. “The burden of command, Mom called it.”

Adora bit her lower lip for a moment. Even now, Queen Angella was a sore subject. “We’re princesses,” she said. “We’re supposed to lead from the front.”

“Technically, I’m a queen.”

The queen, actually, as far as Etheria was concerned. Adora kept her eyes on the screen. The shuttle was quickly reducing the distance to the planet. And to the enemy fleet. No reaction by the Goa’uld so far. But they could be trying to lure them closer, to spring an ambush - send the Death Gliders at them before they could reverse course and flee. “Yes. But I’m no queen,” she said.

“Priest would disagree.”

Adora scoffed. Who cared what Priest thought? His fleet, she answered her own question. She sighed instead of replying.

On the screen, the shuttle suddenly turned around and started flying back. Still no reaction from the Goa’uld fleet. Or flotilla - three Ha’tak and a few more Al’kesh weren’t much of a fleet, not compared to Third Fleet.

“The bombings stopped,” Glimmer commented. “So, no civilians are in danger any more.”

Adora pressed her lips together. They weren’t in any danger any more because they were either safe - or dead.

Then Catra’s smiling face appeared on the screen. “Hey, Adora!”

Adora smiled against her will. That comment brought up so many memories…

“The bombings targetted Jaffa ground forces. They left the mines down there alone, where all the civilians are,” Catra went on. “No sign of a Stargate, though.”

Adora sighed with relief. They could return at a later date, once they had hashed out their alliance with Earth, and save the slaves.

*****

Hyperspace, On the Way to Earth, July 31st, 1998 (Earth Time)

"And… nothing! No connection - the signal remains incompatible."

Even Entrapta sounded a little dejected at the result of their latest attempt to crack the alien data cube, Samantha Carter noted. Unlike their work on the Al'kesh, which had been very satisfactory, they hadn't had much success with the cube so far - it had defied every single one of their attempts to access its core.

"Wellllll…. That means we can try the next theory!"

Not for long, of course - the princess still seemed to have limitless enthusiasm. Sam nodded, though her heart wasn't in it. "Yes, let's attempt to reverse the polarity on the connectors there and see if we get a reading then," she said.

"Exactly!" Entratpa nodded, her hair twitching, then looked at Hordak. "What do you say, Science Buddy?"

"The methodical approach is sound," the former warlord said - he hadn't shown any frustration at their lack of results at all. "Absent other examples of this technology, or individuals of the species that created it whom we could interrogate, we can only work through the various possibilities."

Sam pressed her lips together. She wasn't sure what kind of interrogation Hordak meant. Even after two weeks working with him, Sam couldn't claim she knew him. Sometimes, he acted like the sort of scientist, usually men, who were a little too focused on their work. She was familiar with them, though that also meant she had to be wary of letting her expectations frame her impressions. Other times, the former warlord came to the fore, sometimes just by uttering a suggestion that was unethical, sometimes by mentioning details of his past that drove home the fact that he had waged a war of conquest in the name of an interstellar dictator. The former usually took Entrapta a bit more

time to catch and correct than the latter, which was worrying Sam a little.

But the alien was a very good scientist, Sam had to admit. And as much as it made her question her own morals, she was starting to understand how NASA scientists had been able to work with former Nazis like Werner von Braun. Earth needed to adapt its technology to the level of the various space-faring species, and that meant she and her colleagues needed to understand the alien technology they had access to. And if they had to work with an ex-warlord who might not have reformed as completely as some claimed, then… well, it was better than working with a Goa'uld.

At least Hordak was trying to do better, from what Sam could tell. And, another point in his favour, he didn't show any sort of sexism. He treated both Entrapta and Sam as his equals.

"Alright! Let's prepare the next test!" Entrapta announced and went over to the table where the crystals she had 'attuned' were held.

Hordak nodded and went to the console to adjust the parameters.

And Sam wondered while she changed the adapters on the data cube how she could break it to the Etherians that Earth was a rather sexist society. They were more than halfway to Earth now, and it wouldn't do at all to let their allies - and friends - discover after reaching it that humanity, by and large, wasn't quite as progressive when it came to equal rights for women. Or for people who had non-heterosexual orientations.

The Colonel should have brought it up, but, so far, he hadn't even touched the issue. Daniel had, for a change, apparently avoided the topic in his long talks with the Etherians about their culture. Teal'c… was Teal'c.

Which left her, the only woman in the team, to bring it up. Even if that was against the Colonel's wishes. Not that he had given an

actual order about that. But this wasn't the kind of thing you kept secret.

She sighed.

"Don't worry! Sooner or later, we'll crack the cube!" Entrapta told her with a smile. "Sometimes, science takes a while to get results!"

Sam knew that, of course. "Oh, it's not about that," she said. "I was thinking about home."

"Oh. Don't worry, we should reach Earth in about ten days!"

"Unless we meet another situation that requires intervention or exploration," Hordak added.

Meaning: found a planet with a Stargate on it. They hadn't so far. Which was a good thing, seeing as the route between Etheria and Earth seemed to be outside the Goa'uld sphere of influence, but also meant that SG-1 hadn't been able to inform Stargate Command about their upcoming arrival with an allied fleet. And magical princesses. Not an ideal state.

"Alright! Attempt to connect to the data cube Number three hundred and twenty-six!" Entrapta announced.

Sam nodded and focused on her work.

*****

"Any luck cracking the data cube?" the Colonel asked when they sat down for dinner.

Samantha Carter looked at him with narrowed eyes. He should, by now, know the answer to that without having to ask.

The Colonel flinched a little, which was a small victory. A petty one as well, she had to admit - but the long time spent in a small ship, with limited company, and the mounting pressure on her was

taking its toll. Perfectly reasonable. At least, that was what she told herself.

"We're making progress - we've eliminated several possible architectures today!" Entrapta said between eating her tiny meat pies.

"Well, at least we've cracked the Al'kesh," the Colonel went on. "We'll probably be able to build a copy from scratch at home."

"If we get several key pieces of technology or manage to manufacture them," Sam corrected him. "The crystal-based controls will have to be built from scratch."

"That's what I said," the Colonel said with a grin.

She shook her head and filled her plate.

Catra joined them at the table, stretching her arms over her head, then leaning over to kiss Adora on the cheek. "Hey, Adora!"

"Hey!" Adora smiled at the catwoman, and Sam clenched her teeth. No, this couldn't go on.

She cleared her throat after swallowing a piece of her own, larger meat pie. "There's something we need to talk about…"

*****

"...and while the general attitude has been changing for the better, people who do not conform to the majority view of what is an acceptable sexuality, meaning heterosexuality, are still facing discrimination - legal discrimination, at that."

Catra narrowed her eyes, her tail swishing back and forth behind her, as she alternated between staring at Carter and glancing at Adora. "You mean… your people hate…" she blinked. What was the term she had used? "You mean your people hate people like Adora and me? Or Scorpia and Perfuma? Or Netossa and Spinnerella?"

“Or my dads?” Bow asked. He sounded shocked.

Well, everyone looked shocked. They had known that Earth had some stupid issues with men being considered more powerful than women, which kind of was understandable since Earth didn’t have magical princesses, or scorpion people, or minotaurs, who could toss others around regardless of magic or gender. Understandable, but stupid, of course. But hating people based upon their choice of partners?

“We don’t hate you!” Carter protested. She even sounded as if she meant it. “Nor does everyone on Earth hate you. There’s a significant part of the population that distrusts or dislikes people who do not conform to the heterosexual norm, but few actually hate you.”

That was mincing words, in Catra’s opinion. She didn’t say so, but whether you disliked someone or hated someone didn’t really matter that much, in her opinion.

“And people are changing - society is changing. We’re working on that,” Daniel said. He looked ashamed, at least. “But while we made a lot of progress, we haven’t left all the bigotry behind us. Not yet. But it’s much better than it was in the past. At least in countries like the USA.”

Catra stared at him. Daniel was, as far as she could tell, not one to lie to them.

“That means it was worse? Like with your gender discrimination?” Bow shook his head. “But…why? Why do you hate my family?”

“Why do you hate people like us?” Adora asked in a low voice.

Catra glanced at her and winced - her lover was looking down at the table, and her fingers were digging into her thighs. She reached out to grab one of Adora’s hands, but Adora suddenly looked up, glaring at SG-1.

“Why do you hate us? Why do you want to keep us from… from loving each other?” Adora spat. “Why do you hate love?”

Uh-oh. Catra grabbed her hand and squeezed, hard. When Adora, gasping softly, looked at her, she smiled, leaned over and rested her head on Adora’s shoulder. “I’m here,” she whispered.

“We don’t hate you,” Carter repeated herself. Daniel nodded, as did - although a moment later, Catra noted, O’Neill. “As I said, it’s not a small minority, but neither is it an overwhelming majority.”

“So, what is it? Who on Earth hates us?” Adora asked.

“Ah…” Daniel cleared his throat. “It’s a complicated issue, rooted in our - our country’s - past - and our religion. For a long time, homosexuality, both by women and men, was seen as morally wrong. Usually, religious reasons were given for that, even though the actual scripture of the predominant religion in our country did not condemn homosexuality, as far as most modern scholars agree. It was actually a rather selective interpretation of older passages in scripture, often distorted by translations from the original source, that was seen as a condemnation of the practice.”

Catra blinked. “What?”

“Bullshit,” Glimmer spat. “You want to claim that your god hates us?”

“No, no!” Daniel shook his head. “Sorry, I was… I digressed. No, what I am trying to explain is that while religious passages were cited to justify such a hatred of homosexuality, it was actually based on the culture dominating our country, and much of the world, which, in turn, shaped the religion of our culture.”

Catra blinked again. “You mean… you made your god’s words into what you wanted them to be?” Wasn’t that… going against your god?

“Well, it’s a rather succinct way to word it, but… essentially yes.” Daniel nodded with a short-lived smile. “Even leaving aside the

question of whether or not the god that most of us - most of the USA - revere is actually real, most scholars agree that the scripture was written, and, more importantly, edited and translated later, by people. People who usually had quite specific and sometimes quite personal interests that were reflected in the scripture that resulted from their efforts. Further, they often used expressions that we, lacking the context of their culture and time, cannot interpret with any certainty."

"Get to the point," Glimmer told him, tapping her fingers on the table.

Entrapta was watching with a weird expression, both fascinated and shocked, it seemed, or so Catra thought. And Hordak looked bored. SG-1, on the other hand, mostly looked ashamed. And also angry, in O'Neill's case. Except for Teal'c, who looked like he usually did.

"Sorry. Anyway, according to several scholars - I didn't actually research the matter, unfortunately, since it had no bearing on my work, but I did read a few papers on it - hatred against homosexuals is rooted in a patriarchic culture that values certain traits that are seen as masculine - usually, power, pride, logic and aggressiveness - and considers other traits which are seen as feminine, like nurturing and empathy, as less valuable."

Catra couldn't help but scoff at that. What fool would think those were exclusively male or female traits? These people were so stupid, it hurt.

Daniel cleared his throat again. "This shapes the common view of what is an acceptable way to express your sexuality as well. Men are seen as the active part in a relationship. They are expected to seek out sexual relationships - with women, sometimes multiple women - while women are expected to be the passive partner, serving their lone male partner's desires. Women who express an active interest in sexual relationships are generally disdained by society, while men are generally praised for it. Homosexuals of both genders challenge this view simply by existing, and many

men and women who conform to their society's expectations see them as a threat that undermines society as a whole."

Catra could barely follow the man's rambling thoughts. Even what she understood just didn't make any sense. This was just so… so fucked up! She wanted to rip the guts out of… of someone! She looked at the others, trying to see if they got what their… guests were saying.

Glimmer was frowning worse than she had when they had met during the war. "So, what you are saying is that your society is built on the idea that if you aren't like everyone else, you are a threat, and so you persecute people who don't fit and make up reasons for it?"

Daniel nodded. "Yes. It's a bit more complicated, but essentially, that's correct. Was correct - as I said, we are changing."

"Yes, we are changing," Carter spoke up. "It's taking a while, but we are changing our society for the better. Many people already do not share these views and treat everyone equally. Many speak out against discrimination, and we are working to make others see how bad it is. But making society as a whole change and adapt is a huge undertaking - I faced a lot of sexism as a woman in traditionally male fields, such as the military and the sciences, so I know how hard it is to make people change. A significant part of our people can't just instantly shed centuries of… of tradition."

Daniel nodded. "Change, even unequivocally for the better, frightens many conservative people. New ideas often get dismissed out of hand by them no matter how valid they are. But, over time, change for the better happens."

Glimmer scoffed. "Well, you better be ready to change some more since we won't tolerate anyone trying to tell us whom we can love!"

"Yes," Adora hissed, and, for a moment, Catra thought her eyes were blazing.

*****

The Headstart

Hyperspace, On the Way to Earth, July 31st, 1998 (Earth Time)

Leaning against the wall in his cabin, where he had called an urgent team meeting, Jack O'Neill felt… well, torn. He wasn't happy with his team - except for Teal'c. Not at all. He wasn't happy with the whole situation that Carter's talk, and then Daniel's lecture, had caused either.

On the other hand, if the Etherians had found out about Earth's attitude towards gays after arriving on Earth… He suppressed the urge to wince. That would've been a diplomatic disaster of an unprecedented scale. And he had been aware of that ever since he had first noticed that Adora and Catra weren't just very good friends. And - and that was why he was also feeling guilty - he had known that they had to talk about this before they reached Earth, yet hadn't done so for two weeks. He clenched his teeth. All that didn't change his duties as SG-1's commanding officer.

He cleared his throat and looked at his team. Carter met his eyes without flinching. Daniel looked away. Teal'c didn't show any emotion. "So, what did we learn today?" he asked.

"That the Etherians' reaction to bigotry on Earth was even worse than we feared, and that we should have addressed this long ago?"

Jack wanted to sigh. Daniel was being confrontative. And protective - he knew as well as Jack did that as a civilian consultant, he had a lot more leeway than Carter. But the worst was that Daniel was correct - they should have addressed this before. Still, certain forms had to be followed. "I don't remember anyone asking me if we should bring it up today. I know I'm getting old, but I think I would remember if I had been removed from command of this team." And he did remember telling his team that he didn't want any more such surprises.

"No, Sir." Carter was looking at the wall next to him. "It was a spontaneous decision, Sir."

"Really. And you couldn't clear it with me beforehand?" He raised his eyebrows.

"Sir, I felt my chosen course of action would cause less disruption to the chain of command, Sir."

A lot of 'Sirs' in this statement. "Are you claiming that you wanted to protect me, Carter?" That wasn't how things worked. The officer in command was always responsible for the actions of his subordinates.

"No, Sir."

This time, Jack sighed.

"Would you have let us address this if we had asked?" Daniel raised his chin. "You have been ignoring this for weeks."

So, now it was 'we'. Well, Daniel knew what he was doing. "I was waiting for the right moment to address it," Jack said. It wasn't quite a lie. It wasn't quite the truth, either. And both Carter and Daniel knew it. Carter wouldn't say anything. Daniel…

"And when would that 'right moment' have been? Five minutes before we reach Earth?"

"Presumably after a valiant battle which strengthened our ties to each other," Teal'c said. He ignored Daniel's pout, of course.

"Yeah, something like that." Jack sighed again. "But yes, I might have been a little too optimistic here."

Daniel snorted.

Jack ignored it. "As we found out, explaining how Earth sees same-sex relationships isn't easy."

“Explaining how Earth sees homosexuals is easy,” Daniel retorted. “Excusing it is the problem.” He shook his head. “Jack, these people literally couldn’t imagine why the people on Earth would hate them for their choice of sexual partners! It’s something out of their imagination. Was something out of their imagination, I should say.”

“Yeah. They are aliens, Daniel. Something we shouldn’t forget,” Jack pointed out. Even though he wanted to forget the bit about his own ancestry. “Jaffa have different views and values as well.”

“We do share the same core values, though, especially when it comes to matters of honour and honesty,” Teal’c said.

Jack suppressed a grimace. “Yes, honour and honesty…” He shook his head. “Telling them that half the country thinks they’re horrible sinners might have been honest, but not exactly diplomatic.”

“Honesty is, in my expert opinion, the best course of action with the Etherians,” Daniel said. “Attempts to hide Earth’s… faults… from them would only cause more problems.”

“Yeah, yeah, But there’s a time and place for this, and a way to present the not so nice facts about Earth. Blurting them out over dinner generally isn’t either,” Jack retorted.

“Jack.”

“Daniel.”

“Do you really think that this was a mistake? Or are you angry that the truth came out, and that they look at us as if we were worse than the Goa’uld?” Daniel asked.

That was… Jack clenched his teeth together,

“I do not believe that they consider us worse than the Goa’uld. They were shocked by the foolish superstitions about sexualities common on Earth, but I believe that this was such a heavy blow

because they held us in high esteem." Teal'c nodded slowly at them.

"Yeah, something like that," Jack said. The kids had looked like they had caught SG-1 kicking puppies - or kitties. "But they need to know that we aren't fanatics who want to burn them at the stake for being gay."

"Most of us aren't," Daniel said with a scoff. "I can think of a few people who would happily bring back autos-da-fé."

"Yes, but these people are a tiny, tiny minority," Jack replied. "Most people don't hate gay people - they're just… uncomfortable."

"Like they were uncomfortable with black people settling in the neighbourhood?" Daniel said with narrowed eyes. He really was involved in this.

"Yeah, something like that," Jack said. Before he could think too much about that comparison, he forced himself to go on: "But things changed and are changing."

"And we told them that." Daniel tilted his head and pushed his glasses up his nose.

"Yes, you did."

"You didn't say much, though," Daniel went on.

"You had things in hand," Jack told him.

Daniel stared at him for a moment, then pressed his lips together and looked away.

Jack sighed again. What could he have said? The same that Daniel and Carter had said. But coming from him…

*****

Hyperspace, On the Way to Earth, August 1st, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora sighed as she stared at the ceiling of their cabin. It was… she still had trouble understanding it. "I don't get it," she whispered.

A soft growl sounded next to her. Then she felt Catra's head on her chest move, lift. A moment later, a hand appeared in front of her face, and a finger flicked her nose.

"Hey!" she protested.

"You've been sighing for hours!" Catra complained.

"That's not true!"

"Almost hours," Catra retorted. Then she sighed herself, and Adora felt her shift some more - until she was lying on top of Adora's chest, her arms crossed over Adora's chest, and looking at her. "What's your problem?"

"That Earth hates us!" Adora blurted out. Why wasn't Catra bothered by this?

Catra rolled her eyes in return. "Earth doesn't hate us. Some Tau'ri hate us."

"A lot of them hate us," Adora retorted. SG-1 had been clear about that.

"So? A lot of people hate me, too." Catra shrugged.

Adora pressed her lips together. Catra shouldn't talk like this. Even if it was true. Catra had changed for the better. She wasn't like… like she had been before. But even so… She clenched her teeth. Pointing out that hating Catra for what she had done when leading the Horde, and hating them for loving each other, was very different would be...

Catra flicked her nose again. “Hey! I know it’s not the same.”

And Catra could read her like a book. Adora sighed again.

“Look, SG-1 might not have been completely honest with us - I understand something about that - but they aren’t bad people,” Catra said, twirling one finger around a strand of Adora’s hair - she could feel the tugging.

“Yes, but… How can we work with the others, knowing that they hate us?” Adora started to shake her head, pulling Catra’s fingers back and forth.

Catra rolled her eyes again. “We don’t have to work with all of them. There are six billion people on Earth. We can pick and choose.”

“After interrogating them to find out if they hate us?” Adora asked. Then she blinked - Catra seemed to seriously consider this. “I was joking,” she quickly added.

Catra tilted her head. “I’m sure we can think of something to weed out the bad people.” She flashed her fangs in a wide grin.

Adora sighed again. She knew she wouldn’t like this. Then she sighed another time. “It’s not even that, actually.” She shook her head. “It’s… It makes no sense. Why would anyone hate us for loving each other? If they were jealous, it would make some sense…” She trailed off, biting her lower lip.

Catra snorted. “I know that. But…” She shrugged again. “You heard Daniel - they were taught that we - people like us - are bad people. Like we were taught that princesses were evil.”

“I know,” Adora replied. “But we were taught that princesses were bad, so we’d fight them. Why would you want to fight people like… like Bow’s dads? And don’t tell me that George was a soldier once!”

Catra snorted. “I won’t.” Then she grew serious. “Well, teaching people that someone’s bad and you should fight them also makes them, well… close ranks and follow orders.”

“Oh.” Adora blinked. “Daniel said something about that.”

“Yes. Like unit cohesion.”

“Unit cohesion? For families? And villages? Kingdoms?” Adora shook her head. She remembered those lessons from officer training, but… “It’s still evil. It’s even more evil.” They weren’t at war. They were targeting their own people.

“Yeah. But you heard them - they’re getting better.”

“So what?” Adora scoffed. “We treat them like the Horde after the war?”

Catra nodded. “That’s a good idea. As long as you don’t seduce one of them.” She grinned again. Teasing her.

Adora scoffed. “I didn’t seduce you - you seduced me!”

“You seduced me without noticing,” Catra shot back. Then she pushed herself up on her arms, moved her head forward and kissed Adora. “Now, sleep.”

“Now, get off my chest.”

“Naw.”

Adora sighed again. But she did feel better. Maybe they could handle this without a fight or something. It wasn’t as if they could just leave and let the Goa’uld destroy the planet, anyway. Six billion people. Hundreds of millions of children.

*****

Hyperspace, On the Way to Earth, August 2nd, 1998 (Earth Time)

“You want to fly ahead with the shuttle?” Glimmer frowned. As did Catra. Adora as well, Samantha Carter noticed.

“Yes,” the Colonel said. “I hoped we’d find a Stargate, but… We really need to give Earth at least a few days of advance warning. If the fleet just shows up, there’ll be worldwide panic. Even if no one starts a war by accident, people will die anyway in the chaos. Many people.”

Sam nodded in agreement. “If you drop out of hyperspace outside the Sol system, we can take the shuttle and reach Stargate Command without being noticed.” The stealth system was good enough - Sam knew that.

Yet, the Etherians were still frowning. Catra narrowed her eyes. “That would also allow you to put your own spin on the news.”

Of course it would, but the alternative was mass panic and disruption. Sam pressed her lips together - this had to be handled carefully.

“But why?” Entrapta asked. “We’re not your enemies.”

“But Earth doesn’t know aliens are real,” Daniel pointed out. “And people fear the unknown. Also… a whole fleet instead of a single ship? That will be seen as an invasion, not a peaceful contact.”

That made Glimmer and Adora nod, at least.

“Yes. People on Earth aren’t used to whole fleets showing up to help them out of the goodness of their hearts,” the Colonel added. “They’ll suspect the worst.”

“That’s no surprise,” Catra commented, baring her teeth.

“No, it isn’t,” the Colonel replied with a mild expression.

Catra snorted in return.

“Please.” Daniel leaned forward a little in his seat. “Many people will die if there’s a panic.”

And that convinced them. Sam could tell as the Etherians started to look at each other and grimace.

“How long do you need?” Adora asked.

*****

“So, we’re getting a headstart of a few days,” the Colonel said, once again pacing in his room with the entire SG-1 present. Samantha Carter was sitting on his bunk, actually, next to Daniel. “Congratulations! It looks like we’ve avoided an Independence Day scenario.”

Of course he would make a movie reference.

“I think there’ll be parties on rooftops anyway.” And, equally expected, Daniel would take it and run with it.

“There’ll be parties on rooftops in Los Angeles no matter what,” the Colonel said. “But we’ll have to convince our government to treat this seriously. We can’t waste this chance.”

Would the government actually dismiss their warning? Sam didn’t think so. Stargate Command had built up enough of a reputation over the last year, namely by repelling Apophis’s invasion. On the other hand, SG-1 also had built up a certain reputation…

“So, while it’d be nice to have General Hammond call the president and set everything up just fine, we’ll have to plan for the worst,” the Colonel went on.

Sam leaned forward, her eyes narrowing. What exactly did he mean?

“So, in case Hammond or we get stalled for any reason - for example, to check our credentials, or because something happened to Stargate Command in our absence that led to a

change of command - we need alternatives," the Colonel explained.

Ah. Sam nodded. The alternatives the Colonel meant - bypassing the chain of command - would likely end her career, but this was too important. Too many people would die even in the best case, should the Third Fleet arrive in orbit without warning.

Daniel blinked. "What kind of alternatives do you mean?" he asked.

"Contacting the president directly. Calling your contacts to circumvent any roadblocks. Hacking the emergency broadcast system?" The Colonel shrugged. "Probably not the latter, since that would just cause what we want to avoid."

Sam suppressed a snort. It wasn't funny. Too many people would die if they failed. She could call her father, of course - they were estranged, but this was too important. But would he believe her?

"I don't exactly know anyone I could tell about this," Daniel said, frowning. "Nobody outside Stargate Command who would believe me. Everyone knows me as the guy who was laughed out of his last presentation for mentioning aliens."

Sam winced. Daniel hadn't actually claimed that the pyramids had been built by aliens - he had merely mentioned an unknown, advanced civilisation as a theory to explain discrepancies that had crept up when dating the pyramids - but when someone had mentioned the aliens, he hadn't dismissed the idea either. And the media, as well as his colleagues, had run with it and discredited him in his field. He was known as the kooky alien conspiracy theorist now.

"Well, they'll sing a different tune once the Etherians arrive," the Colonel said. "Provided we can keep World War III from breaking out in the meantime."

Which was a real possibility, if, fortunately, not the most likely. Still… "If our credentials were to be questioned," Sam said, "then

we will be unlikely to have access to communications."

"Exactly." The Colonel grinned. "I'd ask Queen Glimmer to come with us so she can teleport us around if I thought they would let her go on the shuttle with us."

Sam winced again at that. Taking Glimmer with them - well, technically, the shuttle belonged to the Etherians, so it was more the other way around - would be a headache. Some idiot would, 'just to explore all options', ask about taking her hostage, and if the NID got wind of it, or some of the brass got paranoid… It was very unlikely that there would be such a blunder, but not impossible.

"Glimmer or Adora can't go with us," Daniel said. "They don't trust us enough for that."

Sam nodded. Not after their revelations.

"And I don't think they'll let Entrapta come," the Colonel said. "Which - no offence, Carter - is a good thing, or you two would probably build a doomsday device to pass the time while we wait."

Sam dutifully snorted at the weak joke. But she couldn't see the Etherians sending Entrapta with them, either. Not without someone to keep her from being taken advantage of. The thought of some of the more… ambitious officers trying to influence Entrapta made her clench her teeth. Hordak was bad enough.

"So, no help on that front. We'll probably have Bow with us," the Colonel said. "Of course, that means advanced communications. But we'll have to arrange a way to prove that there's a fleet about to arrive without letting everyone else discover them."

"We lack FTL sensors at Stargate Command, Sir," Sam reminded him. There had been work into it, but it had been far from completion - Sam doubted that her colleagues had managed a breakthrough in the time she'd been away.

"I know." The Colonel leaned against the wall. "So, I need more ideas to save Earth if we're locked up."

"We'll have to prepare measures in advance, Sir," Sam said. "And we need to decide where we can land the shuttle without revealing it to the world at large." Cheyenne Mountain wasn't the best choice, being the most important base for the defence of North America. Not many officers serving in NORAD were read in on what actually happened down in Stargate Command.

The Colonel grinned. "Oh, that's easy. There's really only one site where we can land an alien shuttle without everyone freaking out."

Sam blinked. Then she groaned.

Daniel looked confused. "What do you mean, Jack?"

"Why, Area-51, of course." The Colonel flashed his teeth. "It's nicely isolated, and anyone who hears about it will think it's a hoax."

Sam sighed.

"I believe that is called hiding in plain sight," Teal'c added.

Sam still couldn't tell if he was serious or not.

*****

Outside the Solar System, August 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

SG-1 were nervous, Catra could tell. Not from looking at Teal'c, of course; the big man was both built like a rock and could hide his emotions like one. But while O'Neill acted as if he didn't have a care, his jokes weren't quite on point, and he was talking a little too much. Especially compared to the last two weeks, when he had been somewhat restrained. And Carter was fidgeting with her gear as if it might have been broken in the five minutes since she had last checked it. Daniel, at least, wasn't even trying to hide his

nervousness as he sat down, then stood and then sat down again on the ramp of the shuttle.

"So… we're about six hours out from Earth in the shuttle. We could fly closer, of course, since you said you don't have FTL sensors." Entrapta cocked her head.

"We were working on them before we left for our mission," Carter said. "But while it's unlikely that my colleagues managed to complete the project in my absence, it's not impossible."

"Oh, come on, Carter!" O'Neill butted in. "The nerds wouldn't be able to turn on their computers without you!"

"It's not like that, Sir." Yeah, Carter's pained half-smile was a generous reaction to that comment. "We have the most qualified research staff at Stargate Command."

"We have you. And your assistants."

"There's also the potential of being observed by telescopes," Carter went on. "It's a very faint possibility, but not one to be neglected. We're talking about an entire fleet, after all."

Catra snorted. "And you want us to be as far out of your system as possible." She saw Glimmer tense up, and Bow shot her a glare. But she wasn't sorry - someone had to point this out.

"A little delay can often avoid hasty responses," Teal'c commented.

"Yeah. And the further you're out, the less chance that someone spots you and Earth panics," O'Neill added.

"I just said that, Sir."

Yeah, definitely nervous. Catra wasn't actually sure if that was a good or bad thing. SG-1 were, by and large, decent people. They couldn't hold a candle to Adora, of course, and Catra honestly doubted whether any of them would have accepted her in their ranks after all she had done - she was quite sure that they

wouldn’t have given her a second chance if she had spent a few years fighting them like she had the Alliance.

But SG-1 also were competent and experienced. They hadn’t looked nearly as nervous when they had been facing potential Goa’uld traps and ambushes. So, was the situation on Earth really so bad? She glanced at Bow, who hugged Glimmer and whispered something about everything being fine. Well, it better would be fine. If something happened to Bow, things would get ugly. Glimmer would blow up. Maybe literally.

On the other hand, SG-1 would have said something if their idea was putting Bow at risk. They weren’t stupid, after all. So, they were probably nervous about how *they* would be received back on their home planet. Well, that was their problem. Catra didn’t really give much of a damn about that.

Adora, of course, would care, so even in the worst case, SG-1 should be fine.

“So… I’ll contact you in a few days, when Earth’s ready,” Bow said with a half-smile, rubbing the back of his head.

Glimmer nodded, then hugged him again. “Be safe.”

“And don’t wait too long,” Catra said. Advance warning was fine to avoid a disaster, but they wanted to talk to Earth’s leaders. Not to the USA alone. And the longer they waited, the more time the USA had to influence the rest of the world. Well, that was Glimmer’s problem.

O’Neill didn’t quite clear his throat when Glimmer and Bow started kissing, but Catra could see he wanted to. She hadn’t quite figured out what his problem was with kissing or sex, but maybe once they could study Earth’s society, that mystery would be solved as well.

Glimmer and Bow finally separated, and Bow entered the shuttle to prep it for takeoff, followed by Carter and the rest of the SG-1.

Glimmer joined Adora, Catra and Entrapta at the door to the hangar. "If anything happens to Bow…" she whispered through clenched teeth. "I should be going with him."

Catra rolled her eyes. They had gone over this before. Glimmer was Queen and the Commander of the Alliance (as long as Adora didn't contest that, of course). She couldn't go. Adora couldn't go either for similar reasons. And because no one wanted Priest to be left alone at this point in time. If something happened to the shuttle's comm, the clone would probably think it was an attack. Catra would have gone with Bow, but then Adora would worry far too much as well.

So she held her tongue - Glimmer was probably just venting - and watched as the doors closed, and the hangar was depressurised. Then shuttle lifted off and slowly flew out of the ship before speeding up and quickly vanishing in the distance.

"They're on the way. We'll know soon how it goes," Entrapta said. "It's so exciting! A whole new planet! With six billion people!"

Well, at least someone was looking forward to this.

*****

Solar System, Approaching Orbit Above Earth, August 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

This was it. Jack O'Neill did his best to appear nonchalant when Earth grew visible through the cockpit windows. "Well, I guess we better call in, so they know to prepare the red carpet."

"Yes," Bow agreed.

Good. Not that Jack had expected the kid to disagree - Bow was one of the nicest people he'd met in this business. A little like Daniel, just with a bow and no glasses. And a bare midriff.

"The radio is tuned to the gate frequency, and I have checked the encryption, Sir," Carter reported from where she had been fiddling

with the communication suite Entrapta and she had cooked up.

“Thank you.” The codes would be outdated, but it would prevent any radio enthusiast on Earth from picking up the transmission. Or a foreign country. Well, they would pick u the transmission but would, hopefully, think it came from a military satellite. He cleared his throat. “Open a channel.”

“Yes, Sir.”

“SG-1 to Stargate Command, please come in! SG-1 to Stargate Command, please come in!”

He didn’t expect an answer right away. Not a month late and using old codes, and from Earth’s orbit. But they would be scrambling down below. Checking the radar, trying to locate their position. Hammond would be barking orders.

“SG-1 to Stargate Command, please come in!” Jack repeated himself. “General Hammond? I know we’re late, but we kind of got lost. But we found some nice people who hate snakes and gave us a ride home, so I hope you won’t be too mad with us.”

“Sir!” Carter hissed.

He grinned at her - she really should know him better than this by now.

Daniel sighed as if he had anything to complain about.

Bow remained unfazed, but then, Etherian radio discipline was very… flexible, from what Jack had observed.

“Stargate Command to SG-1. State your position.” That was Hammond!

“Hi, General!” Jack said, as upbeat as he could. “We’re currently in orbit, about…” He glanced at Carter. “Carter?”

Carter immediately relayed their position.

"We're in a stealth shuttle to avoid causing worldwide panic and all that stuff," Jack added. "Quite considerate from our new friends."

Then came the expected questions and exchange of signs and counter-signs to prove their identity. Fortunately, Jack was an old hand at that. Hearing Hammond sigh told him he had convinced his commanding officer that they were the genuine article.

Of course, the fact that they were in a stealth shuttle helped with that - Hammond would be aware that they could easily bomb any place on Earth if they wanted without anyone able to stop them. They wouldn't need subterfuge to take Earth.

"Good to have you back, Colonel," Hammond said. "Now, what's this about new friends."

"Well…" Jack trailed off for a moment. Hammon would tense up right now, he knew. "That's a story best told on the ground. Can you call Area-51 and tell them we have a stealth shuttle to land, no questions asked? And get us an inconspicuous flight to Peterson Air Force Base?"

Hammond chuckled, but Jack could tell his commander wasn't really amused. "Are you sure?"

"Yes, Sir," he replied. After a deep breath, he added. "We didn't fly all the way here in this shuttle. Our new friends took us here - one is flying this shuttle. And we've got a fleet of them waiting outside the system."

"Could you repeat that, Colonel?"

Jack winced at the tone. "A fleet of spaceships, sir. Big spaceships with big guns - and they outnumber our Navy. Fortunately, they are friendlies looking for an alliance against the snakes."

"I sense a 'but' there, Colonel."

Well, Hammond knew Jack. “Yes, Sir. They want to talk to Earth, not to the USA. And they won’t wait forever. We’ve got a few days to prepare for First Contact, Sir.”

Another moment passed. “I see. I’ll call Area-51. And the president. This better not be a joke, Colonel.”

“Dead serious, Sir.”

“Stargate Command out.”

Jack sighed as he leaned back in his seat. “That went about as I expected.”

“That’s a good thing, right?” Bow asked with a smile.

Jack shot him a tired glance. The kid was just too naive.

*****

Area 51, United States of America, Earth, August 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“Well, someone has a sense of humour,” Jack commented as they glided in towards the designated landing field - it was marked with a big Roswell-Alien-style logo. “Or someone is about to get canned.” Bow looked puzzled, so Jack had to explain the joke. “There’s an urban legend about aliens looking like that. Supposedly they landed on Earth forty years ago and are kept here.”

“Ah.” Bow nodded. “So, anyone watching us will think this is a joke.”

“There shouldn’t be anyone watching us, but if they are, yes.” Jack nodded.

Then they touched the ground, and he saw a platoon of soldiers rush out to surround the shuttle. “Alright, let’s face the music, team! Be all nice and friendly - Hammond must have lit a fire

under the base commander to get us landing clearance so quickly, but they'll be suspicious. Bow, just… stay on board, OK?"

"OK!" Bow nodded. "And if anyone tries to enter, I'll just lift off."

"Yes." Hopefully, nobody would be as stupid as that, but you never knew.

"The shuttle should withstand most attempts to enter," Carter remarked.

"Unless they start with trying to blow the doors open," Jack replied. "So, let's go, team! See you soon, Bow."

"Bye!" The kid waved at Jack.

Jack shook his head as the ramp was lowered.

*****

Outside the Solar System, August 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Incoming call."

Adora turned, pulling her hair out of Catra's hands, as she heard the announcement. "Accept it!"

"Hello, everyone!" Bow appeared on the screen on Darla's bridge.

"Bow!" Glimmer beamed at him. It was the first time she had smiled in hours, and Adora felt a little guilty about it - Catra hadn't gone with SG-1, after all.

And Bow smiled back. "Glimmer! How are you holding up?"

"Oh, it's fine. A little bored but fine."

Catra coughed behind Adora's back, but Adora ignored it and Glimmer's lie. "How are you doing?"

“We’ve safely put the shuttle down on Earth,” Bow told them. “Some sort of secret base - but it’s in the desert, in the open. They had to put some tent over the shuttle.”

“What?” Catra frowned. “A tent?”

“A mobile tent of sorts, yes.” Bow shrugged.

“Big enough to cover the shuttle?”

“Oh, yes. Jack said it’s to cover prototypes.”

“How does that work when flying?” Entrapta asked.

“It’s not meant for flying, apparently.”

Adora shook her head. That didn’t make much sense.

“Anyway, SG-1 left - they took off with an aeroplane and should arrive at their base in an hour or two,” Bow said. “No one bothered me here, no one tried to get into the shuttle - Jack ordered them to leave me alone.” He frowned. “I’m not sure if they even know that I’m on board.”

“Used to keeping secrets,” Catra commented.

“Of course they are!” Glimmer blurted out. “They kept the Stargate secret. And their war with the Goa’uld.”

“Well, as long as you can blast through the tent if you need to…” Catra grinned.

“That shouldn’t be a problem,” Bow replied.

“So,” Entrapta cut in with a wide smile, “did you test my receiver already?”

“Ah.” Bow smiled. “I’ve tested it, yes - it can receive the transmissions from Earth.”

“And the television broadcasts too?” Entrapta leaned forward. “Does my adapter work? The autotuning?”

Bow nodded. “I had to adjust a few settings, but yes - it’s basically the same principle as SG-1s radios.”

“So…?” Entrapta fidgeted. “Can we watch Earth entertainment now?”

Bow nodded. “Yes, we can, but…” He grimaced.

“What’s wrong?” Adora asked.

“It’s a little… Well, you have to see it to believe it,” Bow said. “I’m relaying the signal now.”

Adora watched as another screen lit up on the bridge. Then she frowned. “What’s a ‘Jerry Springer Show’?”

*****

Stargate Command, Colorado, August 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“...and then we landed at Area-51,” the Colonel finished. “From there, we returned to base.”

Samantha Carter sat straight in her chair and looked at a point to the left of General Hammond’s shoulder without showing any expression on her face. Even though she wanted to wince a little - the Colonel had summed up their experiences in a slightly flippant manner. Well, they had been thoroughly examined in the infirmary, and the Colonel always was a little annoyed after that.

“I see,” the General said with a frown. “You’ve made contact with an advanced civilisation willing to help us against the Goa’uld.”

“And they followed us home,” the Colonel joked. “And we can’t get rid of them.”

“And we really need to call the government,” Daniel spoke up. “General. If the Etherians lose patience, then they’ll cause a mass panic on Earth.” He leaned forward, as Sam saw with a glance. “We don’t have much time to prepare Earth for their arrival.”

“And there is no chance that these ‘Etherians’ can be persuaded to abandon their plans of revealing their presence to the entire world?” the General asked.

This time, Sam winced.

“No, Sir,” the Colonel replied, shaking his head. “They’ve left absolutely no doubt that they want to contact Earth and not just the United States. They do not recognise us as representatives for Earth.”

“The president will not be happy about this,” the General said, leaning back. He was still frowning. “An alien space fleet about to make contact with Earth. The Stargate program revealed. The Goa’uld threat exposed.” he shook his head. “This goes against every standing order.”

“It’s not as if we had any choice in the matter, Sir,” the Colonel told him. “The only way to avoid this would have been to refuse their offer to fly us back to Earth. And while some members of our government would be very happy if we had decided on that, I think making an alliance with a power strong enough to give the Goa’uld pause is more important than secrecy.”

Secrecy that was very unlikely to survive the next attack by the Goa’uld - it was a miracle that Apophis’s attack hadn’t exposed the Stargate program.

“The Etherians have proven their mettle,” Teal’c said. “They will be mighty allies of the Tau’ri.”

“Unless the government screws this up,” Daniel added. “They aren’t happy with several of the country’s policies.”

The General turned to look at Sam. “What’s your opinion, Captain?”

“Sir, we need this alliance,” Sam replied at once. “The Etherians’ technology is more advanced than the Goa’uld’s. They have hundreds of ships, their military has experience fighting a war in space, and they are willing to protect Earth.”

“They’ll protect us whether we like it or not,” the Colonel cut in. “They’re kind of like that. And they have the power to get their way.”

“The President won’t like that either,” the General said.

“That won’t change the facts.” Daniel shook his head. “We need to inform the world about this so people can prepare for their arrival.”

The General slowly nodded with a deep sigh. “I think so as well - but many will disagree. And some will doubt your report.”

Sam knew what and who the General meant.

“We can call Bow and ask him to tell the fleet to shoot their guns. Telescopes will pick the flares up,” the Colonel said.

“Let’s hope it won’t come to that.” The General got up. “I’ll call the president.”

Sam sighed - silently - with relief. But she hadn’t expected General Hammond to doubt them in the first place. The real problem would be persuading the government that they were telling the truth about the Etherians.

*****

Stargate Command, Colorado, August 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and did you see those ships with your own eyes, Captain?" Senator Wooley, his broad face and bald head visible on the screen in the room, asked. How this man had gotten on the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, Samantha Carter couldn't understand.

She had to make an effort not to glare at him - they had covered that question already. "It's a space fleet, sir," she replied. "The distances involved are too big to be able to see the whole fleet with your naked eye. But I saw and rebuilt the sensors used to detect them, and I saw enough of the ships close by to be confident that the numbers we cited are true. The electronic data is also supporting this."

The man frowned at her from the screen across the table. "So, you could have been deceived about their actual power."

Not for the first time, Sam wished that the President wouldn't have decided to treat the whole event as a bipartisan affair and involve the Senate at this point. It could cause critical delays. "I consider that very unlikely, Sir," she replied with all the composure she could muster.

"Well, you wouldn't know if you were deceived, would you?" Wooley sniffed.

Sam clenched her teeth. Wooley hadn't made any openly disparaging remarks, but she was familiar with his attitude towards women in the military from his interviews, and it grated on her nerves that a man who had never served himself was looking down on her. But he was a Senator. "Leaving aside the facts that I just told you, Sir, there's also the question of what the Etherians could gain by such a deception."

Another sniff. "You told us about their agenda."

"Their stated objectives focus on an alliance with Earth against the Goa'uld, Sir. If they were weaker than they claimed, we would find out quickly in the field."

“But then they would have already achieved their objective.”

“Which objective do you mean, Sir?” Sam didn’t raise her eyebrows.

He didn’t take the bait. “That remains to be found out, Captain. That’s obviously not part of your expertise but ours.”

She couldn’t help herself - she frowned in return.

Fortunately, Senator Smith, the chairman of the committee, stepped in at this point and appeared on the screen, replacing Wooley. “Captain Carter comes highly recommended, James. Her service record speaks for itself.”

“This is a matter of policy, though, Jim. And that’s our purview.”

The President’s actually, but Sam wouldn’t point that out.

“And we’re here to gather the information we need to make a decision,” Smith said. “Captain Carter, you stated in your report - well, Colonel O’Neill did, but you signed it as well - that you don’t think that the Etherians will be reasonable and limit their contact with Earth.”

“Yes, Sir. They’ve made that absolutely clear.” Sam nodded sharply.

Wooley cut in again. “We haven’t talked to them - all we have is the testimony of Captain Carter, Colonel O’Neill, an archaeologist and, apparently, an alien infected by the same kind of parasite we’re supposed to be at war with.”

“You’ve read the files, James,” Smith replied, a little more sharply.

“I’ve tried to - this was all sprung on us a few hours ago. There wasn’t enough time to actually study everything in detail. It’s already a scandal that we are at war with an alien power, and Congress wasn’t informed!”

Which, technically, was true, though there were good reasons for that.

"That's another matter which will have to be discussed at a later date. We have more pressing problems to settle," Smith commented. "But selected members of Congress were informed."

"Which will also be discussed, mark my words!"

Sam didn't sigh.

Smith cleared his throat. "Back to the business at hand. Captain, I think you've detailed the military situation quite clearly. But you've also observed and interacted with the leaders of this 'Princess Alliance' for close to a month. This committee would like to hear your impressions, especially of their political views."

"Yes, Sir." Sam took a deep breath. "The Princesses Alliance is made up of the most powerful kingdoms of Etheria. It was formed in a war against the Horde - a war that was only recently concluded. They're mostly absolute monarchies led by a hereditary ruler."

"With magic powers. Magic princesses," Wooley didn't appear on the screen, but Sam knew he was sneering.

"The rulers of Etheria have powers that would be best described as 'magical'," she went on. "Those powers have been observed by my team and myself. Dr Jackson is of the opinion that those powers were crucial for the development of Etheria's current political structure, and I agree."

"Yes, we've read that." Smith slowly nodded. "Leaving the exact nature of their powers aside, do you think they plan to colonise Earth?"

Sam had expected that question. "No, Sir."

"And what do you base this opinion on?"

“My personal impression of the leaders of Etheria,” she replied. “They are, in my opinion, honourable and decent people, not conquerors.”

“Nothing else?”

“No, Sir.”

“That’s not much.”

She didn’t reply to that.

“And what if you’re wrong?” Wooley butted in again. “They are the absolute rulers of monarchies. What if they want to conquer us? What do we do in that case?”

“If they want to conquer us, Sir, then asymmetrical warfare would be our best and only means to resist. The technological gap is just too big for organised warfare.”

“Even with the technology you’ve recovered and studied?” Smith asked.

“Yes, Sir. We haven’t mass-produced any of the weapons we found.” They hadn’t produced any advanced weapons, period, but that was a detail. And they had gone over this before.

“I see. So, back to the Etherians’ capacity for warfare…”

Sam suppressed a sigh. They were wasting time here. Time they couldn’t afford to lose. The Etherians wouldn’t wait forever - who knew what they were doing right now?

*****

The Reveal

Outside the Solar System, August 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"OK… Earth entertainment isn't all bad."

Catra, still giggling, frowned at her lover. "What? That had been hilarious!" she protested. The way those people kept stumbling into traps… Not at all like the Jerry Springer Show. Why would anyone want to watch friends - family - tear into each other? The whole show had reminded Catra of a time she really didn't want to remember.

"It was OK," Adora said, shrugging. "Pretty entertaining."

"Bah!" Catra scoffed. "Let's watch another cartoon! But not the one where the cat always loses!" That one was biased and bad.

Adora snorted at that - of course she would! Catra frowned at her, but she smiled even more. "That one was funny, though."

"It was… OK," Catra replied in a flat tone and narrowed her eyes at her lover.

Then Adora laughed in that carefree way of hers that reminded Catra of their time as cadets before things got bad, and Catra couldn't help joining in.

"I'm still not sure that the Jerry Springer Show was actually entertainment," Glimmer commented after a moment. She was frowning - probably jealous that Bow was stuck on Earth.

"It was called a show. Shows are entertainment," Entrapta replied. "The news and documentaries are educational." She smiled. "We've recorded a number of those while we watched other shows."

"Yes!" Adora nodded. "We need to learn more about Earth!"

Catra groaned. Not everything should serve the mission.

"What about this? It's a documentary about Earth food?" Entrapta pointed at an item on the screen.

"Like the cooking show that we watched earlier?" Catra leaned forward. That had been entertaining and interesting. So much food and so many new swear words.

Adora nodded. "Yes, let's watch that."

"It's mostly about meat, I think," Entrapta said.

"Meat is good," Catra commented with a smirk. Adora missed her meaning, though.

Then the documentary started. And Catra started to wonder if that had been a good idea. "People eat that on Earth?" All the birds looked like they were sick!

"I'm not going to eat any meat on Earth," Adora mumbled.

"I'm not going to eat anything on Earth," Glimmer added.

"It's a very efficient way to produce meat without cloning tanks," Hordak commented. "I might have to adjust my opinion of Earth's culture."

Entrapta whapped him on the head with one of her hair strands without taking her eyes off the screen.

And Catra swallowed what she had been about to say. In hindsight, trying to make a joke about dead animals wasn't nice.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, August 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill knew jetlag would get him sooner or later. But he'd manage a few more days. He had to - everyone was going crazy

about the arrival of the Etherians. It helped that he had been able to sleep during the flight to Washington and that the day/night cycle in Third Fleet had been off compared to Earth. Still, he was running on coffee and jello. And a sandwich some poor aide must have grabbed from the mess hall.

He resisted the urge to shake his head - he had to be professional. The perfect soldier. These people had to believe him, or things would turn into a catastrophe.

"I'm still not convinced that we should let these aliens dictate how they contact Earth," Senator Brown-something - the civilians lacked name tags - said with a scoff. "This is our planet, and we need to draw a line in the sand from the start. History proves that."

Jack wondered what history the man meant. Columbus? Or Perry?

"Eugene, while the exact number of space ships on their way to Earth might have to be readjusted once we can independently verify it, I can tell you that even a handful of space ships represents a force that our forces cannot resist," Kinsey said. For once, the man was actually helping.

"Robert! You knew all about this!" Brown-Something glared at his supposed colleague. "Of course you'd say that!"

Jack had to struggle to keep from sniggering. Yes, as the chairman of the Senate Appropriations Committee, which controlled the Stargate Program's budget, Kinsey belonged to the small group of politicians who had been read in about Stargate Command and the Goa'uld. If it came out that his decisions had almost led to Earth being conquered by Apophis, Kinsey would be done for.

Unfortunately, revealing that would probably also bring the government down - things had been very dicey, after all. So, Jack couldn't hint at a few of the angry Senators who had just a day

before heard that aliens were real and Earth was at war that they should look into that particular incident.

"I'm saying that because I know it's true. The United States cannot stand against even a small fleet," Kinsey insisted. "And the President shares my view on this."

More snorting from the politicians at the table. But even some of the brass seemed sceptical, Jack noticed.

"We've been updating our capability to intercept space-born threats," General Naird said. "But it's a slow process, and we've been handicapped by the need to keep our advanced technology secret."

"Alien technology," Kinsey corrected him.

Jack almost nodded in agreement. As head of the Air Force Space Command, Naird had been read in about Stargate Command as well. The general should know better than to act as if he wasn't involved in the whole coverup.

"Yes, yes." Naird shook his head. "But even if we don't need to keep the technology secret any more, we would still look at several years to upgrade our space defences to what we would consider operational."

"And we only have a few more days before the black ships arrive and force our airports open," Brown-Whatever commented with a glare at Jack. "Because you failed to impress upon those aliens how things are done on Earth. Princesses! Absolute Monarchies! And those people are about to dictate terms to us!"

"They won't," Jack said with more confidence than he felt. "They fought a war against an invading Horde for decades; they won't invade another planet in turn. We know them."

"So you say, Colonel O'Neill." The politician sneered at him.

“Eugene, if the aliens want to invade, why would they announce their arrival in advance? That doesn’t make any sense. If they were planning to conquer Earth, they would have struck without warning.” Kinsey shook his head. “They certainly wouldn’t have sent SG-1 ahead to inform us about them.”

Jack refrained from nodding in agreement. It was still Kinsey.

“They could be planning to divide us!” Brown - Brown-Smalls, Jack finally remembered the name - spat. “They force us to inform the rest of the world to undermine our leadership of the free world!”

“They said that they want to talk to the whole planet, not just to the USA,” Senator Willsbury, an older woman, pointed out. “They’re not exactly being subtle there.”

“They wanted to arrive without warning, but we managed to persuade them that we needed some time to prepare the world,” Jack added.

“And you couldn’t persuade them to negotiate with the United States instead?”

“I’m sure the Colonel and his team did their best,” Kinsey, smiling, cut in before Jack could answer.

“Well, their best obviously wasn’t good enough!” Brown-Smalls scoffed.

This time, Jack glared at him. “I can assure you, Senator, that if you had been in our place, they wouldn’t even dream of talking to the United States at all.”

“That’s enough, Colonel,” General Naird spoke up. “We’re here to determine what realistic military options we have should this First Contact turn hostile.”

“We already did that, sir,” Jack reminded him. “We do not have any realistic option to withstand the Etherian fleet with either conventional or nuclear means. We could resort to asymmetrical

warfare as long as the Princess Alliance remains in command since they do not want to hurt civilians. Unlike the Goa'uld."

Naird frowned as if it was Jack's fault that he didn't have a few brave space fighters to attack a mother ship. Which the Etherians didn't have anyway. Because Adora had turned it into a giant space plant. With magic.

But if Jack mentioned that, everyone present would think that he had gone crazy.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, August 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Ah, Colonel O'Neill. Captain Carter." The President looked as if he had aged years since Jack O'Neill had seen him last. "Glad you could join us."

"Mr President." Jack and Carter saluted. Daniel almost followed suit but nodded instead.

"Sit down somewhere. There should be food in a bit - we've ordered dinner." The man gestured at the long table in the situation room. "Ladies and Gentlemen - the Pentagon finally released SG-1 to us."

SG-1 without Teal'c. Jack was still grumpy about that. 'Security considerations' his ass - Teal'c had proven his loyalty many times over! Apparently, the Goa'uld larva in his stomach pouch suddenly represented a risk for the President and his cabinet.

The assembled men and women nodded at them.

"We've already reviewed our military options," the President went on. "And since those boil down to 'surrender or become guerillas', we're here to discuss our political options."

"They should have been doing that from the start," Daniel whispered.

"I'm sure they have," Carter whispered back.

Jack cleared his throat.

"Your input will be invaluable for this - you know the alien leaders and how they think."

"Thank you, Mr President," Jack said.

The rest of the Cabinet nodded as well, but Jack could see some sceptical expressions amongst them.

"So, we'll tell the world tomorrow. Our allies will be informed beforehand, of course - they'll be mad enough about this secret being kept from them. Especially the Brits." The President laughed, and so did everyone else. "But we haven't yet decided how to handle the aliens themselves. That means we have this night to come up with a plan of action. I need ideas, people!"

"Well…" the Secretary of Defense spoke up, "we've read the briefs about the Etherians. They want allies for their war with the Goa'uld. The United States are the most advanced nation on Earth - technologically, militarily and industrially. We've been fighting the Goa'uld for years, so we're the natural allies of the Etherians. They need our manpower and industrial capacity."

Many at the table were nodding in agreement, Jack saw.

"If not for some of our policies," the President said, tilting his head. "Such as 'Don't Ask Don't Tell' and our general problem with bigotry and racism."

"Racism wasn't in the brief," the Secretary of Commerce protested.

"Did you miss that the queen's consort is black?" the Secretary of Education told him. "Not that it matters - the intel we received

was clear: Our current stance towards gay rights is the biggest obstacle to forming an alliance with the Etherians."

"If we can be allied to Saudi Arabia despite their policies on pretty much everything except for Iran and making money, I doubt that a few internal matters will be a problem for the Etherians. They're fighting the same enemy as we are fighting - an Empire of body-snatching snakes," the Secretary of Defense retorted. "Winning the war takes precedence. Etheria only has fifty million people and is not nearly as industrialised as we are, according to our information. They need us as much as we need them. Who else would they ally with? The Russians? China? India?" He scoffed.

"Etheria isn't a democracy," the Secretary of State pointed out. "And they are aliens - they have a different view of what is a good system for government."

"But everyone's track record with regards to gay rights is worse than ours. Do you really think that aliens concerned about bigotry will ally with countries that violate human rights every day?"

"Several states in Europe have a better track record, to use your words." The Secretary of State shook his head. "France will jump at the chance to get out of our shadow - and they won't have much of a problem with adjusting their internal policies. Germany too," he added.

"They'll certainly have far less trouble changing anything than we'll have," the Secretary of Education said. "The conservatives will fight this tooth and nail."

"We can use Executive Orders," the Secretary of Defense retorted. "If we actually have to do a thing. I'm still not convinced that the leaders of an alien planet would be overly concerned about gay marriage on Earth."

"Would you care to answer that, Dr Jackson?" The President turned to face them.

Daniel took a deep breath. “Yes, Mr President. The first thing you need to understand is that Etheria’s kingdoms are ruled by monarchs,” he said. “Monarchs with special powers who govern as mostly absolute rulers.”

“I thought they were absolute rulers?” the Secretary of Defense asked.

“Even absolute rulers depend on a bureaucracy, advisors and regional sub-rulers,” Daniel explained. “And depending on the situation of the realm, they have to consider all those people when making decisions.”

“Ah.”

“Although in this case, the current rulers of the dominant kingdoms of Etheria seem to be rather secure in their power - they have recently defeated an invasion by an alien power, the Horde. One could actually make a case for there having been two invasions…” Daniel coughed. “Anyway, the important point is that the personal prestige of the princesses in the Alliance is currently at its peak. Combine that with unparalleled personal power and it is very likely that their people are firmly behind every decision they make.”

Jack could see some grim expressions there.

“To illustrate that, as our report stated, an entire fleet of clones worship Adora, also known under her title of She-Ra, Princess of Power, as a goddess,” Daniel went on.

“Your report also states that this She-Ra doesn’t like it yet cannot stop them. This seems to be a limit of her power,” the Secretary of Education said.

“This is correct in that she can’t stop the worship or hasn’t managed so far. But they will obey her other commands almost blindly,” Daniel replied.

That caused more grim expressions.

"So, the princesses are used to getting their way," the Secretary of Agriculture spoke up.

"Mostly, yes. They are also close personal friends." Daniel smiled. "And this leads us to the crucial point: Etheria takes what we could call matters of state very personally. Princesses are expected to lead from the front, so to speak. Alliances are as much or more a matter of personal relationships and character as of necessity or state - their alliance is called the *Princess Alliance*, after all. And, well… they have voiced concerns that they might form an alliance with a country on Earth, and a few years later, the leader of a country on Earth might be replaced, and the alliance might be broken - that's because they are used to forming alliances with rulers, not nations."

"Christ! It's like we're in the medieval age!" the Secretary of Commerce blurted out. "Do we need to arrange dynastic marriages to get anything done?"

Jack thought the man was joking, but his laughter rang more than a bit hollow.

"The Brits would like that, I bet," the Secretary of Defense commented. "They've got two princes in the right age range."

Daniel, of course, took the question seriously. "It would be a mistake to consider Etheria as a technologically advanced copy of our own medieval age. They developed the way they have due to the specific circumstances of their planet and their population. Dynastic marriages are, actually, not the norm on Etheria - the rulers tend to pick their partners for love and without concern for someone's social standing. One of the most powerful princesses is, according to her friends, expected to formalise her relationship with a smuggler any day now, for example."

That had most of the Cabinet blinking with surprise, in Jack's impression.

“Do we need to call in George Lucas as an advisor?” The President chuckled.

Jack laughed at the joke, and even Daniel got it. Carter, of course, merely smiled.

But Jack’s friend grew serious at once. “And this is the crux of the matter: The Etherians were shocked by our stance towards minorities. When we informed them of the state of our society with regards to gay rights, they had trouble understanding the mere concept of discrimination based on sexuality, gender or - presumably - race. I have to stress this: They were shocked by the fact that this was happening on Earth.”

“Ultra-progressive princesses. Now I’ve seen everything,” the Secretary of Defense mumbled.

“Their political views might cause some consternation amongst the pundits,” the Secretary of Education commented.

“More importantly,” the President spoke up, “their views are a problem for us. We look like a bunch of bigots to them - and they take that personally. Dr Jackson, how do you think they’ll react when some of our more prominent pundits voice disagreement with the lifestyles of Etheria?”

Daniel frowned. “I think they would be hurt if a televangelist called them Whores of Babylon. They aren’t used to such… diverse opinions. Or mass media. For them, politics is a deeply personal affair.”

“Do they expect us to abolish Freedom of Speech?” the Secretary of State asked.

“No, I don’t think so.” Daniel shook his head. “We have covered that aspect of democracy in our talks. But I think they’ll still emotionally struggle with such attacks. They are, after all, all very young compared to the average political leader on Earth.”

"Idealistic college students turned absolute monarchs. I can see the next Disney movie," the Secretary of Agriculture mumbled.

No one laughed this time.

"Yes, that sums it up, folks." The President nodded. "So, how do we ensure that they realise that we aren't the antichrist? We need this alliance. Not just to protect Earth, but also to preserve the United States as a world leader."

"Ah." Daniel was smiling apologetically, Jack noticed.

The President nodded at him. "Yes, Dr Jackson?"

Daniel cleared his throat. "Religion is actually another crucial issue. The Etherians plan to restore magic to Earth, after all."

"What?"

Jack had the impression that most of the Cabinet had overlooked that part of their report. Or had failed to take it seriously.

"And people keep telling me to write better reports," he mumbled.

Carter shot him a glare, of course.

*****

Outside the Solar System, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"They've announced a press conference at the White House for the afternoon!"

Adora blinked at Entrapta's exclamation. "A what?" Then she blinked again. What was Entrapta doing in her bedroom?

"It's a thing where they tell people news!" Entrapta, balancing on the foot end of Adora and Catra's bed, beamed at them. "At least that's the logical deduction from the reactions I saw on the television broadcasts!"

Catra groaned and rolled off Adora. “And you woke us up for that?”

Entrapta nodded. “Yes! It’s so exciting! We’ll be able to watch Earth’s reaction to the information about our impending arrival as it happens! Just imagine all the data we’ll gather!”

Adora blinked once more. “Uh, Entrapta… how much did you sleep last, uh, night?”

“Err… I didn’t? But I’m totally fine - I got enough tiny concentrated tea inside me to be fine!”

Adora made a mental note to have a talk with Hordak about Entrapta’s eating habits. “So… when will this news conference happen?”

“In the afternoon!”

“Our afternoon?” Catra asked. Her lover had finally opened her eyes, Adora noticed.

“Yes!”

“And it’s…” Catra turned her head to look at the clock on the sideboard.

Adora quickly wrapped an arm around Catra and smiled at Entrapta. “Why don’t you go tell Glimmer now? We’ll be up in a bit!” Fortunately, she managed to clamp a hand over Catra’s mouth before her lover started hissing and trying to wriggle out of her grasp to claw Entrapta or something.

“Oh… are you engaging in foreplay?” Entrapta tilted her head. “That’s usually done in private, though, as far as I know.”

What the…? This was… Adora’s face felt like it was burning. She gaped at Entrapta.

"Oh, right, sorry!" Entrapta hurried out of the door before Adora could correct her.

As soon as their friend had left, Adora relaxed with a sigh and released Catra.

"See what you've done?" Catra hissed and smacked her on the head.

"She means well," Adora said.

"I know." Catra groaned and rolled on her back. "But it's seven in the morning. And we watched that stupid show until three."

And hadn't gone right to sleep, either. But that was neither here nor there. "It wasn't a stupid show, or we wouldn't have watched it for so long."

"I was just keeping you company!"

"Your eyes were glued to the screen!"

Catra sniffed. "I didn't want to make you feel bad." Then she yawned. "Now, let's get some more sleep before Entrapta notices."

That was a good idea. Adora pulled Catra in close and pressed a kiss on her head. They could watch television later.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

When she saw the Colonel enter the Situation Room, he looked… well, Samantha Carter couldn't say rumpled since his uniform was perfectly pressed. But she knew the signs of fatigue on him.

"How much did you sleep, Carter?"

As he knew the signs on her, apparently. "We were dismissed to get some rest at the same time, Sir," she replied.

“That’s not an answer to my actual question, Carter.”

She felt herself wince. “I had to amend our reports, Sir.” There had been no choice, though - she had to amend the parts about magic since those had obviously not been given enough weight by the Cabinet.

“Carter! We need you at your best! This is a crucial moment for the entire world, and you can’t give your best hopped up on coffee.”

“Yes, Sir.” She carefully nodded and stared at him.

He didn’t blush, but he frowned. “I had to give a personal report to the president.”

Sam suppressed the sudden spike of resentment. The president asking the commanding officer was just a logical move. Even though she should’ve been there as well. And Daniel, of course.

“It wasn’t much - just my personal take on the princesses,” the Colonel went on.

“Yes, Sir.”

A loud yawn announced Daniel’s arrival. “Sorry… I slept a bit too long. They had this old book in the guest room…” He smiled at them. “So, how are things?”

“News Conference at two in the afternoon,” the Colonel replied. “NATO partners have been informed already.”

“What about the Russians and the Chinese? India?” Daniel asked.

The Colonel didn’t shrug. “They were, as far as I’ve heard through the grapevine, informed that this wasn’t a joke and not aimed at them, but that there might be some social unrest.” He chuckled. “The Russians probably know about this by now due to some KGB mole left in Brussels.”

Daniel blinked. “Seriously?”

The Colonel snorted. “I’m joking. At least I hope I’m joking. The Russians were good, though, back in the Cold War.”

“Ah.” Daniel looked around and then headed for the pot of coffee.

“So, the police are going to be mobilised?” Sam asked.

“And the National Guard. And the Army. And the fire brigades, of course, and all the other emergency services.” The Colonel sighed. “This is such a goddamn mess.”

“Well, this would have happened sooner or later,” Sam pointed out.

“I just wish it had been later rather than sooner,” he replied. “Preferably after my retirement.”

She didn’t snort at that - the Colonel wouldn’t retire for twenty years. But he would retire from active frontline duty sooner than that. And maybe she wouldn’t be in his chain of command any… She clamped down on that thought. She really was a bit too tired.

“Well, let’s prepare for the end of the world as we know it,” he said.

*****

“So, where do we stand with Congress?” the President asked when he entered the room half an hour later. He looked a little tired as well, Samantha Carter noticed, but not nearly as tired as she had expected.

“They’re not happy with us,” the Vice President told him.

“Not happy with me, you mean.” The President chuckled. “What are the chances you’ll be in my seat a month from now?”

"Low. They're angry at being left out of the loop about a war in space, but we should still have a majority behind us. But you might have to make some sacrifices."

Of course, Kinsey cleared his throat at that. "If I may, Mr President."

"Yes?" That was more than a hint of a frown, Sam noticed.

"We do have a majority right now, but that could change should news of the attack by Apophis leak." Kinsey sounded just the tiniest bit of smug, though his expression didn't betray any of that.

Next to Sam, the Colonel cursed under his breath. Sam was tempted to join in. Both of them knew where this was going.

Kinsey sighed. "If they decide to raise a stink about the fact that Earth was a few hours from orbital bombardment without any measures taken to warn people and get them into shelters…" His grimace was as fake as his concern, Sam thought. But he was correct. People wouldn't take well to hearing that. And she strongly suspected that the news would leak in the wake of today's revelations. Certainty if Kinsey was about to get canned for his own part in it.

"Everyone involved would have to resign," the President said with a grim expression.

"We'll be lucky if they don't shoot us in the streets," the Secretary of Defense mumbled.

"We can handle the people," Kinsey said. "They won't know how fast spaceships are. Saturn might as well be on Alpha Centauri for all they know. We tell them we stopped the invasion far out, and they'll be happy enough. But that won't work on Congress."

The President narrowed his eyes. "And you can handle Congress."

Kinsey smiled almost apologetically. “I can talk to a few people, make them understand that the last thing we need right now is an Impeachment. America more than ever needs strong leadership in this crisis. We’re in a war after all.”

The President stared at him for a moment. “Do it.”

Kinsey’s smile turned more genuine as he nodded. “I’ll get on it, Mr President.” He left the room.

The President sighed. “Well, let’s hope he can deliver. Now, about our allies… How unhappy are they?”

“Very, Mr President. Very unhappy.”

“I hate to say it,” the Colonel mumbled to Sam as the Secretary of State started to detail the responses from the other NATO members, “but I’m hoping that Kinsey got more dirt about his colleagues than we thought.”

Sam had to nod in agreement. The senator was correct - the last thing the USA needed right now was a change of government. That wouldn’t build a lot of trust with the Etherians. Not at all.

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Outside the Solar System, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Entrapta didn’t look like she had slept at all, Catra noticed when she entered Darla’s bridge. Her friend was still acting as if she had just drunk another can of concentrated tea - which she might very well have, actually. Well, they would have to force her to rest after this.

“Ten minutes to the start of the press conference!” Entrapta announced. “Look, they’re already broadcasting!”

On the screen, Catra could see a large room filled with people, an empty pedestal and small desk, and several people in uniforms.

Not the same as SG-1 had worn - those must be the 'dress uniforms' Daniel had mentioned.

"...and speculation is running wild as to the content of this surprising press conference. We've received reports that the police not only in Washington D.C. but across the entire country has been preparing to handle rioting. Chuck?"

The image shifted.

"Yes, Betty, indeed, I am standing in front of the headquarters of the LAPD, and the mood is tense. You can see various officers checking the transports and preparing riot control gear. But no one seems to know what this is all about."

"Thank you, Chuck. We've also received news that NATO states are doing the same thing - and have also announced press conferences. Whatever it is, this is big, folks! Very big!"

"Not only that, Betty, but we've received news that Russia and China are moving army formations into cities. Some people worry that this might start a new Cold War - or, even worse, an actual hot war!" another man said.

"Well, if Russia wanted to start a war, I doubt they would move their army into their cities," Betty replied. *"But speculation is indeed rampant. Alan?"*

The screen shifted to show a man standing in front of a fence. *"Yes. Rumours after rumours are spreading. Even the most absurd speculation is repeated across Washington."* He laughed. *"The most outrageous is tied to reports that Dr Daniel Jackson has been seen in the White House for the last few days. For those who don't know, Dr Jackson was an archaeologist who became briefly famous for his theory that the pyramids were built by aliens."*

As apparently the entire news crew laughed, Catra shook her head. "Someone's going to be sorry for that in about… five minutes."

Entrapta nodded.

“Daniel will be happy to be proven right at last,” Catra said. “I wonder if he’ll talk to the press as well.”

“You mean give an interview?” Adora asked.

“Everyone is giving interviews.” Glimmer snorted. “SG-1 are the ones who met us, so they’ll be asked all sorts of questions.”

“Like in the show that we saw,” Adora nodded.

“He better make us look good,” Catra muttered.

“Catra!” Adora frowned at her.

“What?” Catra smiled at her lover. “I’m just saying… they wanted a headstart to prepare Earth for our arrival, they should use that to make us look good, so they won’t be afraid of us.” All the preparations that were mentioned on the screen were a little concerning. Would the people on Earth really freak out just because they heard about the Alliance?

Adora snorted, and Glimmer rolled her eyes.

“They need to know that the fleet is able to protect them. That way, they’ll feel safe,” Hordak added.

Glimmer cleared her throat. “I don’t think that’s how it works. They don’t know us, so they don’t trust us.”

“Once we’re in orbit, they’ll see that they can trust us when we don’t conquer them even though we could do so easily,” Hordak retorted.

“I don’t think we could conquer Earth easily. Or at all,” Catra said. “They’ve got millions of soldiers and all those weapons. Even if we transported all of Etheria and all the clones and bots down there, we couldn’t garrison them.” And as SG-1 had told them, Earth

people were used to fighting even after being conquered. And she wasn't going to say what Horde Prime would have done to Earth.

Neither did Hordak or anyone else - but they all knew it.

"Oh, it's starting!" Entrapta piped up in the sudden silence.

And, indeed, an old man was stepping up to the desk, smiling widely. That must be the President.

"My fellow Americans! Today is a historic day. An age-old question of humanity will finally be answered: Are we alone in the universe? And the answer is: No, we are not alone in the universe. The United States has made contact with extraterrestrial intelligent life. Peaceful contact."

The room exploded in noise. A red banner appeared on the bottom of the screen with the words 'Existence of aliens confirmed' and started scrolling from right to left.

"Please, please…" The President raised his hand. It took a while for the room to quiet down. *"I'll answer questions after my statement."* He nodded.

"Now, in addition to SETI, for several years, the United States has been running a top-secret program to search the galaxy for intelligent life. We have been doing this by means of an alien artefact that was found on Earth and painstakingly restored and returned to service. An artefact that allows travel to distant planets through a gate network that covers a lot of the galaxy. Brave teams of explorers went through those gates to explore the stars. This is our Stargate Program."

Catra frowned. That didn't…. Well, it *did* fit the story SG-1 had told them about the Stargate Program, but only if you creatively shuffled things around.

Once more, whispers started, and the banner changed to 'Aliens exist - U.S. teams travel the galaxy.'

"The reason this was kept top secret is that not all aliens are peaceful and friendly," the President went on. *"In fact, some of them are hostile, and we've…"*

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Catra shook her head at the reaction of the people on the screen. The President - or was that the Mr President? - barely could continue his speech over all the cries and shouting. He tried anyway, but it seemed to make things worse.

"They are panicking," Hordak said. "He just told them that they defeated the Goa'uld twice, and that new allies are about to reach Earth, and they are still panicking. I question the need of making an alliance with such people. They will run at the slightest danger."

"Those are civilians, not soldiers," Adora retorted. But Catra could tell that she was taken aback as well.

"They did expect riots," Catra said. "That's why they were all so tense."

Hordak huffed.

"I don't have any news of riots," Entrapta announced.

Catra glanced at her and gasped. She had cables stuck to her visor and… "How many channels are you watching at the same time?"

"Six. No, seven. But all of them are focusing on the press conference," Entrapta replied. "Even though they're just shouting at the moment."

"Their military does not seem to be very competent either if they cannot restore order in the room," Hordak said. "Their leader is not supposed to have any magic powers with which he could defend himself, is he?"

“No, he isn’t,” Catra told him.

“Then he is at risk. This might be a coup.”

“No, it isn’t. But they’re not going to send their military against their own people,” Glimmer said. She looked rather angry, Catra noticed. “And it’s no surprise that the people there are panicking - they have just been told that their leader hid a huge secret from them for years and that their country is at war. Why wouldn’t they be upset?”

“Why would they trust him?” Adora asked. “They must feel betrayed.”

Ah. Catra clenched her teeth when she understood. Adora was feeling for those people - this must remind her of her experiences with the Horde propaganda.

After minutes of pointless shouting and yelling, the President was able to continue his speech.

Although people kept trying to interrupt him. And their reactions…

Adora grimaced. “They really didn’t like hearing that SG-1 has been fighting the Goa’uld for several years.”

Catra nodded. Well, she could understand that. Though if you told the troops everything, operational security would be dead, and morale would drop at the slightest reversal. Hell, Mermista’s people had deserted her at the mere rumour of a damaged Runestone and a Horde Fleet sailing towards them. The Earth people were doing pretty well so far. And now the President was talking about Etheria. And he was making them look good!

And then came the questions. And Catra started frowning. Some questions made no sense at all. Why were they asking if the Etherians had grey skin and big eyes?

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Well, this went… as badly as expected," Jack O'Neill said as he sat down in one of the chairs at the wall in the Situation Room.

"They haven't set fire to the Capitol. Or the capital," Daniel objected. "And the rest of the world hasn't declared war on the United States. Both of which were deemed possible if not very likely scenarios, if I recall correctly."

"Give'em time. Both can still happen," Jack mumbled, craning his neck until the back of his head touched the wall. "People need some time to get to a riot."

"It's started in Los Angeles, Sir," Carter reported, looking at her laptop. "And there are traffic jams in the greater Washington area as some people flee the city and others flock to Washington after several groups have called to protest this 'flagrant violation of the constitution and the trust in our government', to quote one."

Jack sighed. "Any good news?"

"The police seem to have the riots in hand so far, Sir," Carter replied. "Although if this spreads too far…"

Members of the Cabinet started filtering in as well. A few looked shell-shocked like green soldiers after their first fight.

"We're receiving sharply worded diplomatic notes from all over the world," the Secretary of State said. "Apparently, the British have figured out where the Stargate came from. They're all but calling us thieves."

Jack scoffed. "It was found in Egypt, not England. And Egypt was an independent country at the time. At least formally." He noticed Daniel looking surprised and rolled his eyes. "I once did a report on the country at the Academy."

"Sorry." Daniel looked embarrassed at his earlier surprise.

The Secretary of State chuckled. “That will be our answer. Of course, the Egyptians also protested - they must have put two and two together after CNN revealed your presence, Dr Jackson.”

“Oh.” Daniel blinked.

Jack shook his “That was fast.”

And that, of course, made Daniel frown at him - as Jack had known it would. “Don’t underestimate other countries, Jack. Humans aren’t stupid as a rule no matter their culture.”

Jack pointed at the big screen, which was now showing burning cars in Los Angeles and a breathless reporter talking into the camera. “Looks pretty stupid to me.”

“People are scared, Jack, and scared people lash out.”

“The French are facing similar riots. The United States embassy required additional protection,” someone said.

More and more reports were brought in by a swarm of young aides and interns.

“Russia’s president is making a speech.”

“China’s gone silent - they’ve cut the internet and cited a national emergency to stop foreign correspondents from reporting. Last we heard, tanks were moving to Beijing.”

“People are calling for a gathering at Area 51.”

“Germany’s voicing concern about the possibility of a war being conducted from our bases there without their knowledge.”

“The French are calling for a ‘reevaluation’ of NATO structures.”

“Los Angeles reports the first death in the riots.”

“Several people suffered heart attacks during the press conference. We’re still getting a count.”

“The National Guard has moved to secure the Capitol and the White House.”

“Canada is demanding a full accounting of the Stargate Program’s use of shared resources in Cheyenne Mountain.”

Someone must have leaked the location of the Stargate. No, they probably recognised Daniel, Carter or Jack himself and realised the truth. “I hope that the Etherians are feeling sorry for inflicting this on the world,” Jack muttered. They probably would, unless he had completely misjudged their characters. Well, Hordak probably wouldn’t feel sorry at all.

“I think so, Sir,” Carter said.

“To be fair, Jack,” Daniel said. “I honestly doubt that more time would have changed anything. You can’t really ease the world into the fact that we’re at war with aliens.” He frowned. “Of course, it could’ve been much worse if the Etherians had showed up without warning, but this was probably the best we could’ve hoped for.”

Jack sighed again. Daniel was right. And the more the people knew about it, the bigger the risk of a leak. Still… “This could’ve gone better.”

“Bill’s calling for a bipartisan congressional inquiry into the Stargate Program!” someone yelled.

“Bastard!”

“He’s just playing to the crowd!”

“Can we counter that?”

“What the hell’s Kinsey doing? He should’ve prevented that!”

“If it’s a bipartisan effort, then we can sink this.”

“That’s what they want!”

"It's just showboating for the crowds. Besides, there's already congressional oversight. He's just angry that he's not on that committee."

"It's just a waste of time. We can give them that to placate them."

"Right. But where's the President?"

"Still on the line with Russia."

"I thought the Russian president is at a Press Conference?"

"It's been delayed."

"They just want to be seen to be doing something."

"They seem more concerned about this investigation than the riots and the reactions of the rest of the world," Daniel said.

"Welcome to politics," Jack muttered.

Someone next to him laughed. He looked over, and it was the Secretary of Defense. Damn, Jack should've noticed the man sitting down. He must be more tired than he had thought.

"It's not like that - or just a bit," the man told them. "But we've been anticipating the reaction of the rest of the world, and of the people. They're more or less following the script. But Congress shenanigans? That's not as predictable as foreign policy."

Jack nodded, even though he didn't completely agree. The man was his nominal superior, after all.

But they were now, to borrow a term from the Navy, in uncharted waters. And Jack wasn't looking forward to discovering that they were headed for an underwater reef.

*****

The Repercussions

Outside the Solar System, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and the riots are spreading as a growing crowd is gathering at the foot of the Washington Monument and demands answers from our government…"

"...Bundeskanzler hat erneut versichert, dass die Bundesregierung über das Stargate-Programm nicht informiert war, und…"

"...Her Majesty's Government can neither confirm nor deny this at this point, though…"

"...rumours of the armed forces shooting at protesters with lethal ammunition…"

"...dozens of buildings are burning, and the police struggle to clear the lanes for emergency vehicles as the crowd refuses to budge, and…"

"...Paris est sûre, la France est sûre, mais…"

"...the death count from the Alien Revelation is rising. Dozens of deaths have been confirmed already in the United States alone, and…"

Adora shook her head at the rapidly changing sights of burning buildings and masses of people throwing rocks at soldiers. Rocks and burning bottles and… "Why are they doing this? This makes no sense!" she exclaimed. This was insane!

"They're angry and scared," Glimmer said. "And they feel betrayed."

"But this doesn't help anyone!" Adora protested. "How does attacking a… a market help you or anyone else feel safer? Or solve anything?" It wasn't even a government building!

“This never happened in the Horde,” Hordak commented.

“Because anyone doing it would have been shot,” Catra pointed out.

“Yes. Such a lack of discipline cannot be tolerated.”

“They’re not soldiers,” Glimmer told him through clenched teeth.

“Then they should be treated as bandits or marauders.” Hordak shook his head. “This is a disgraceful display.”

“People are dying!” Adora snapped. “And they are dying because they are afraid of us!” This was their fault. Her fault!

“Or because others are afraid of us.” Entrapta pulled her mask off. “People also died in accidents trying to flee the cities.” She looked… disturbed.

“Yes.” Either way, they had caused this. “We shouldn’t have insisted on revealing the Stargates and us,” Adora said. “SG-1 told us that this would happen. We should have listened to them. This is our fault. My fault.”

“No, it isn’t!” Catra snarled. Adora looked at her with a gasp - her friend was showing her teeth. “You didn’t lie to them and kept an entire war a secret! They did that, even though they knew what would happen once the secret was revealed!” She stepped up to Adora, glaring at her. “Don’t you dare let anyone blame you for this! You didn’t do this! They did this to themselves!”

“Yes. They lied to their own people.” Glimmer nodded, but Adora couldn’t help feeling that her friend sounded as if she was trying to convince herself.

So she shook her head. “But we could’ve kept this secret.”

“No, we couldn’t,” Catra retorted. “We need Earth in the war. Earth, not some tiny group of soldiers, no matter how good they are.”

“Yes,” Hordak agreed. “The more resources and troops we can muster, the better the war will go. And that won’t be possible as long as Earth as a whole remains unaware of the war against the Goa’uld. Although given their reaction to the revelation, I do think we should reevaluate their suitability as allies.”

Adora took a deep breath. Catra was probably right. Yes, Adora hadn’t been the one who hid such a secret from Earth. And Hordak wasn’t completely wrong - they did need Earth to fight this war. Yet… “I can’t help feeling guilty,” she whispered.

And felt arms embrace her as Catra pressed herself against her. Adora took another deep breath, suppressing a shudder she was sure Catra would feel anyway, and hugged her back.

“It’s not your fault,” Catra whispered. “Don’t blame yourself for this.”

“I know,” Adora whispered back. But knowing wasn’t feeling.

“Uh…”

“Yes?” Gimmer turned to Entrapta.

“I think Bow might be in trouble.” Entrapta pushed a button, and the screen changed again, showing a reporter looking in the camera with a crowd behind him… in the desert?

Adora gasped as she released Catra.

“...crowd outside famous Area-51 is chanting while facing soldiers securing the road to the famous base. And the crowd is growing as people keep arriving. The mood so far is not violent, but this might change at any moment!”

“Show us the aliens! Show us the truth! Show us the aliens! Show us the truth!”

“That’s where Bow is!” Glimmer blurted out. “Bow! Darla, put Bow on the screen!”

A moment later, Bow appeared on the screen. He was smiling in that forced way he did when he was feeling guilty, Adora noticed. But this wasn't his fault!

"Bow! There's a crowd outside your ship, and you didn't tell us?" Glimmer glared at him.

"Uh… they're outside the base. Way outside. The soldiers keep them back," Bow replied.

"You still should have told us!" Glimmer shook her head. "This is too dangerous! You should return at once!"

"But we'd lose access to the television broadcasts!" Entrapta protested, then cringed at Glimmer's glare. "Can he stay in orbit at least?" she added with a weak smile.

"If I lift off, they'll notice - and that would cause even more trouble," Bow said. "They might storm the area."

And that would cause even more deaths, Adora realised. "We should've called you back right away," she said.

"Yes, come back, Bow!" Glimmer said.

But Bow shook his head. "No. Even if they break through and reach the base, they cant break into the shuttle. And I can always lift off then." He smiled. "We need to trust the people here."

"Bow!" Glimmer shook her head.

"Please."

Both of them looked at each other so… Adora looked away and hugged Catra again. This was such a mess!

And no matter what her friends told her, no matter what she told herself, she couldn't help feeling bad about it.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and seven hours after the riots started, Los Angeles is deadly quiet, with a curfew enforced by the National Guard after the Alien Riots, as they have been christened, have been finally brought under control. The final death toll remains unclear but is reported to be in the dozens."

Samantha Carter tried to ignore the television running in the corner of the Situation Room and focus on her work. She had a report to write, after all. At least an aide had brought a chair with a small desk built-in - probably taken from the press room - so she didn't have to type with the computer resting on her knees.

"Can someone switch the channel?" the Secretary of Defense asked. "They've been repeating themselves for the last half an hour."

"Sure we can," the Secretary of Education replied. "Do you want to listen to 'alien experts' or to military analysts being stupid for a lot of money?"

The Colonel, sitting next to Sam, snorted while the two secretaries glared at each other. "It's like winning the lottery for the crazies," he said in a low voice.

"They called me crazy as well," Daniel said. "And we do know that there was contact with aliens in the past."

"And we also looked at their theories. If any of them had known anything important, we'd have recruited them. Hell, it was you who debunked most of their theories."

Daniel frowned, Sam saw, in that pouty way of his. "Yes, but they're not exactly crazy. The Goa'uld did influence ancient cultures, just not in the way most of them thought."

Sam still couldn't really believe that the likes of Erich von Däniken and Giorgio A. Tsoukalos had been hired by the Swiss government

as advisors.

"Yep." The Colonel nodded. "'Aliens posed as gods and enslaved humans' wasn't a very popular theory back then." he shook his head. "And that little tidbit got the people riled up the most."

"Well, I would say that the fact that the Goa'uld still want to enslave us was the important part," Daniel retorted. "And that they tried it twice in the last few years."

Sam nodded in agreement.

"And we beat them both times," the Colonel said. He held up a hand before Sam or Daniel could object. "I know, I know - we were very lucky. But they don't know that."

"Not yet," Daniel said. "It'll get out sooner or later."

"And we can deny that we were just lucky," the Colonel said. "Also, as soon as the Etherians land and make official contact, people will forget about the snakes for a while."

Sam would agree with him, but she really had to finish this report - the Cabinet needed to know what kind of advanced technology the United States could hope to develop without alien help, and in what time frame, if they wanted to make an informed decision about how to approach the upcoming negotiations with the Etherians. And Daniel needed to finish his addendums to his report about the Etherian culture.

"Alright, folks!"

She looked up again - the President had just entered. And he was smiling rather tiredly.

"I've just finished talking to our NATO allies. The good news is that while officially, they're all very annoyed with us for not telling them about our war with the Goa'uld, unofficially, they were more accommodating. Not even the French are talking about leaving NATO, though everyone wants to discuss how this will affect the

treaty." He sighed. "The bad news is that they're talking about strengthening NATO structures and leadership to address this unprecedented development."

"Why is that bad news?" Daniel whispered.

"That's Diplomatic for 'we don't want you to call the shots any more'," the Colonel replied. "Not that it will succeed - we're just too big and too powerful. Or were."

And indeed, most Cabinet members sighed, and the Secretary of Defense hung his head.

Then the President turned to SG-1. "So… what's your take on this? Will the Etherians build an Alliance with NATO?"

Sam drew a sharp breath and pressed her lips together. This wasn't her speciality. This was Daniel's. And the Colonel's.

"Daniel?" The Colonel looked at their friend. "What do you think, based upon their culture, the Etherians will do?"

"If we approach them honestly, I think so," Daniel replied without hesitation - he must have anticipated this. "NATO would likely remind them of their own Alliance on Etheria."

"And will they associate the Russians with the Horde?" the Secretary of State asked.

"I think that depends on the Russians, Mr President," Daniel replied. "But as long as we're honest with the Etherians, I believe they'll be honest with us."

"We aren't about to lie to aliens who can glass a continent from outer space," the Secretary of Defense cut in.

"They wouldn't do that anyway," Daniel said. "But they will ask for assurances that whatever treaty they make with us won't be dissolved by your successor, Mr President."

"That means I can't just use Executive Orders to push through gay marriage." The President sighed and sat down. "I should never have signed the Defense of Marriage Act. This will be ugly. If we can't do this, the rest of NATO might just make their own deals. And we would need a bipartisan majority for this."

"That won't happen. If the conservatives agree to this, they'll lose the evangelicals," the Secretary of Education said. "And they'll get primaried."

"But we might get enough of them to let it pass. We just need enough to pass the bill; they can oppose it as long as we get enough votes," the Secretary of State said. "Kinsey might get enough of them to play ball."

The President shook his head. "Let's see first if Kinsey had success before we plan on him doing more. And there's the Supreme Court to be considered."

Before anyone else could voice their opinion, an aide entered the room. "Mr President! The crowd in front of Area-51 tried to force their way into the area. Security repulsed them, but… they weren't gentle about it."

"What?"

The aide started to repeat their news, but the President waved him off. "No, I got that. How many are dead?"

"Uh… we don't know yet if there were any deaths, but…"

In the background, someone had switched the channels.

"...and it's carnage as the army beats down people left and right! Bleeding protesters are arrested as dozens of people cry out for help!"

"Air Force," Sam heard the Colonel mutter under his breath. "It's an Air Force base."

Sam wasn't quite certain that the Air Force would want to be associated in the perception of the public with this particular incident.

"Well, that doesn't look so bad," the Secretary of State said - right before a young woman bleeding from the head and carrying a young child in her arms, both crying from tear gas, staggered through the scene behind the reporter.

"Who takes a child to such a protest?" Daniel wondered, shaking his head.

The reporter, meanwhile, kept talking. *"Behind me, parts of the crowd keep chanting despite the tear gas deployed. They want to 'free the aliens', as they say."*

"Christ!" the President cursed.

"Can we evacuate the alien? He looks human, so we could stuff him in a uniform and just walk him out," someone - the Secretary of Labour - asked.

"We should have brought him to Washington right away," the Secretary of Transportation added.

"I doubt that the Etherians would have let us," the Colonel spoke up. "Bow didn't come as a diplomat - he came with us to make sure we wouldn't do anything with the shuttle."

"And we can't order him around," Daniel reminded the others. "If you want to talk to him, you have to ask him."

"If he's just a guard and pilot, why didn't he leave as soon as you were dropped there?" the Secretary of Transportation asked.

"Because the Etherians probably used the opportunity to spy on us," the Colonel replied.

"What?" several voices exclaimed at once.

“They can’t do that!”

“How dare they!”

“Shut up! We’d do the same!” the Secretary of Defense snapped. “They’re doing SigInt most likely.”

He was looking at SG-1, Sam realised. At her. “Yes, Sir.” She nodded.

“They’re probably watching TV,” Daniel added. “They were very interested in Earth entertainment since they don’t have such mass media on Etheria.”

“Jesus Christ,” the Secretary of Education muttered. “We will be lucky if they want to talk to us at all after this.”

“We warned them what the consequences of this revelation would be,” the Secretary of State pointed out.

“I don’t mean that,” the woman replied. “I meant after they watched our Daytime TV.”

“Oh dear,” someone else muttered.

“People, focus!” The President raised his voice. “We’ve got the boyfriend of the alien queen sitting in a shuttle in an airbase under attack by a mob. If anything happens to him, we’ll get the blame from everyone.”

“We need to ask him to go into protective custody - if the crowd manages to storm the base, we can’t protect the spaceship,” the Secretary of the Interior said. “And if the crowd keeps growing, we won’t be able to protect the base. Not unless we start shooting people,” he added before the Secretary of Defense could protest.

“And we don’t want to shoot people,” the President said. “Alright, call the base. Tell them to contact Bow. No, tell them to get us a line to Bow.” He turned to SG-1. “You talk to him. Make him understand how critical this is.”

"I doubt that he will leave the shuttle, Mr President," the Colonel replied. "I doubt that the mob can force their way into the shuttle there, either. Or even reach the actual base. They have to cross miles of desert."

"Yes," Sam added. "They would need specialised gear or explosives to breach the doors of the craft." She blinked. But…

"But we don't know who is hiding inside that mob," the Colonel said. "If there are operatives of other groups present… We'll need to tell him to evacuate with the shuttle if the situation grows worse. With the crowd drawing attention, a small group of operatives could slip through the perimeter."

"What?"

"Fly away on TV? Everyone will think that we have been hiding aliens!" the Secretary of State protested. "They will think that we've already made contact on US soil!"

"It's better than letting a mob charge the shuttle on live TV," the President retorted. "Or have some foreign spies get access to the aliens. Do it! Get that shuttle away. We can always claim it had an automated pilot or was remote controlled or something."

"Yes, Sir."

"Get me the commander of Area-51 on the line!"

"I need to talk to the NATO General Secretary!"

"Mr President! The United Nations Secretary-General wants to talk to you!"

*****

Outside the Solar System, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"They want to attack you?" Glimmer was… well, not hysterical, in Catra's impression. More like ready to blow up a few Earth people.

"Bow!"

"Well, they are screaming about 'freeing the aliens', so they probably don't want to attack me…" Bow, smiling weakly on the big screen, told them. Then he glanced over his shoulder. "The soldiers are fighting them, but… there are so many."

"They seem to have limited weapons," Hordak commented. "SG-1 used firearms to great effect, but those soldiers are using clubs and rather ineffective gas."

"I think they are trying to avoid killing the people there," Entrapta said.

"But they are losing the battle."

"Ah…" Bow coughed. "It's more a protest than a battle. I think so, at least."

"It looks like an attack on a military base to me," Hordak said.

"These people aren't soldiers!" Glimmer protested.

"Why would that matter?"

Hordak didn't seem to understand. Well, Catra didn't quite get it either. If you didn't want to be a soldier, you didn't attack soldiers, period.

"Oh… another call's coming in. Earth frequency. SG-1's," Bow said.

A moment later, O'Neill's voice was heard. *"Bow?"*

"Yes?"

"I'm with the President here. Things are getting a little dicey out there, which you might have noticed."

"Yes, I noticed." Bow laughed more than a little forcedly.

"Good. Can you fly without being seen on TV?"

"The stealth system is aimed at sensors, mostly. We didn't quite get the optical camouflage working past prototypes. Yet," Entrapta cut in.

"Ah. You're on the line as well. Anyway - unless you want to take shelter in a bunker on the base, it would be better if you lifted off."

"Yes!" Adora spoke up. "If they see that the shuttle left, they might stop trying to storm the base!"

"Or they think that their prey's getting away," Catra commented. She knew the thrill of a chase, after all. And the frustration when you failed.

Adora pouted at her. "But that makes no sense!"

"This whole thing doesn't make any sense," Catra retorted.

"Yes," Hordak agreed. "It's a bandit attack on a base, and the soldiers aren't defending the base."

"It's not a bandit attack," O'Neill protested. *"Those people aren't bandits. They think they are doing the right thing - well, most of them."*

"The Horde soldiers thought the same," Adora retorted.

Catra bit her lower lip. She had known that the Horde was evil, after all.

"Anyway, the base security forces aren't going to massacre a bunch of rioters or protesters. That's not how we do things. So, if those people break through the perimeter and might get to you, lift off. Would be nice if you could wait until it's too dark to see the shuttle lift off, but… there might be other elements out there as well."

Catra nodded. Yes, she didn't think that would work out - it was a few hours until it was dark enough for that, after all.

“We’re not going to risk Bow!” Glimmer protested at once.

“We won’t,” Adora said.

“Of course not,” Bow added. “But I’ll hold out as long as I can.”

Glimmer stared at him, her lips moving without a sound, and Catra sighed and looked away. This was getting a bit too… too much. Then she felt Adora’s hand on her shoulder. “It’ll be OK! They said things are calming down,” her lover said in a soft voice.

“So…” O’Neill’s voice sounded through the speakers again. *“Have you decided what will be your next step? So we can avoid another set of riots?”*

Catra scoffed, then gritted her teeth when she saw Adora flinch. It wasn’t her fault. “You should have thought about that before keeping the whole affair a secret,” Catra spat. “Don’t blame us for that!”

“Well, keeping it a secret was a sort of thing, back in the day,” O’Neill replied. *“But we need to deal with how things are now.”*

“We will approach and address Earth in a day or two,” Glimmer said. “Waiting any longer would only cause more rumours and hysteria.”

“We will?” Adora mouthed.

“Ah. And have you decided on where you’ll land?”

Catra frowned. O’Neill was too… accommodating. She’d expected him to suggest some landing sites.

“Yes,” Glimmer replied. “We’ll ask to land at Geneva to address the United Nations.”

“The Swiss will need some time to prepare for that,” O’Neill replied. *“As will the rest of the world. So… best wait a day after asking for permission to land there.”*

“Then we will approach Earth tomorrow,” Glimmer told him. “We don’t want to delay this any further. Your people need to see that we come in peace and as friends.”

“That’s what we’ve been telling them. But not everyone is listening to us.”

Well, that was no surprise, in Catra’s opinion - not after they had been lied to for years. She clenched her teeth when she remembered what Shadow Weaver had done to her and Adora.

“They’ll listen to us,” Glimmer told him.

“We’ll see. Some might find that a bit intimidating.”

“What?” Adora shook her head. “We’re not intimidating! We’re honest. We’re here to help you!”

Catra sighed. She loved Adora, but sometimes… Well, Catra wasn’t entirely sure that Glimmer hadnt meant to sound so threatening just now. Not with Bow in sort of danger.

After a bit of more back and forth talk, O’Neill ended the call.

“Uh oh!”

“Bow?” Glimmer gasped. “What’s going on?”

“The crowd’s breaking through!” Entrapta announced. The screen switched, and they saw a mass of people surging past and over a thin line of soldiers.

“Bow! Lift off!”

“They’re still miles away, and they have to walk through the desert to reach us,” Bow said.

“Lift off!”

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

On the screen in the Situation Room, the scene changed once more to show a huge tent lifting into the air, picking up speed, before being ripped away and apart by the air resistance, revealing the back of the Etherian shuttle as it climbed into the sky. As before, the scene froze right at the moment where one could see most of the craft.

Then came another set of 'experts' to point at vague features of the shuttle and try to make sense of them. If the situation wasn't so serious, Jack O'Neill would have laughed at some of their ideas.

"How did they break into the base?" the Secretary of Agriculture asked, shaking his head. "The base is supposed to be guarded!"

"They didn't," the Secretary of State told him. "They breached the perimeter of the restricted area. They're still miles away from anything important, like the actual base and runways. Miles of desert."

"Yes," Jack spoke up - perhaps out of turn, but this was about the Air Force getting maligned. "This isn't like a helicopter lifting off the roof from the embassy in Saigon."

"And a lot of our best troops are busy protecting the cities from riots," someone else added.

"But they went through the soldiers!"

"Should the soldiers have shot them? In front of the press? In front of the Etherians? While they were in the middle of the desert, miles from reaching anything actually important? They still are in the middle of the desert, by the way," the Secretary of Defense said.

"So, the Etherians overreacted?" Secretary of Agriculture asked.

“Everyone overreacted,” the Vice President grumbled. “Half the Senate thinks the aliens were almost caught by a mob. No thanks to the press coverage.”

“The Etherians probably didn’t want to take any risks,” Daniel suggested. “I think they’re pretty spooked by what’s been going on all around the world. And there was the risk of foreign spies approaching the shuttle.”

“Well, that’s their own damned fault,” the Secretary of Defense muttered. “We told them what would happen, and they didn’t listen.”

“That’s not quite true, Sir,” Daniel objected at once. “They insisted on contacting Earth, yes - but they didn’t force us to keep the existence of aliens and the Stargate a secret in the first place and for so long.”

“We could’ve handled this if we had been given more time,” the man insisted.

Jack disagreed with that. Not out loud, of course.

Daniel, of course, did so out loud. “Perhaps the consequences could have been mitigated to some degree,” he said. “But the information that we’re at war with aliens who want to destroy and enslave us and that the United States government has kept this a secret from everyone would have caused riots anyway.” He weathered the glare from the Secretary of Defense without flinching.

Jack cleared his throat. “What’s done is done. We need to focus on what has to be done next.”

After a moment, the Secretary of State spoke up. “We know that the Etherians overreacted to this. Do you think that they panicked? Or do you think they had the wrong information to make their decision?”

Jack tilted his head. “Probably a bit of both. Bow probably wouldn’t have lifted off so early. But Glimmer’s back outside the Solar system, and she struck me as quite protective of him.” It wouldn’t hurt to emphasise this before someone got a stupid idea about leverage.

“Are you sure?”

“No, Sir. But this is my best bet. I doubt that Bow would have panicked,” Jack said.

“Unless he panicked about what Glimmer would do if she thought he was in immediate danger,” Daniel added.

Right. Some of the stories they had heard during their trip made that a rather likely assumption.

“It’s a theory, Sir,” Carter said. “We don’t know what the Etherians are thinking right now.”

“They’re probably thinking the worst of us after everything that’s happened,” Daniel said.

Which, honestly, wasn’t a bad stance for them, Jack had to admit, if only to herself. And not an entirely bad thing for Earth either. If someone managed to take advantage of Adora’s… idealism, for example, the consequences when the others, especially Catra and Glimmer, found out wouldn’t be pretty. Still, they had lost a lot of trust today, Jack was sure of that.

The President entered again, looking exhausted. “So… NATO thinks we’ve been holding out on them again.” He sank into his chair. “I’ve explained that this was just the shuttle that brought your team back, but now they want to talk to you.”

“The General Secretary wants to talk to us?” Jack asked.

“He does. But our allies want a Defence Minister meeting to assess the situation.”

"Did you tell them that the aliens want to land at Geneva to talk to the United Nations?" the Secretary of State asked.

"I did. That's what prompted this 'request'. And, as the French put it, since SG-1 will have to be present in Geneva anyway, you can stop in Brussels on the way over."

"Great." Jack sighed. "At least we can sleep on the plane."

"Yes. While I'll deal with the Russians and the Chinese. Again."

Somehow, Jack couldn't muster a lot of sympathy for the President right now. Not when his team and himself had to face a bunch of angry Defense Ministers, and everyone was looking for a scapegoat.

At least he would finally be able to sleep for more than an hour or two.

*****

Outside the Solar System, August 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Bow should return to us at once," Glimmer said, folding her arms over her chest.

"No!" Entrapta objected. "He needs to stay in Earth orbit so we can monitor the broadcasting of Earth! He's perfectly safe there!"

"Bow shouldn't be talked about as if he were not present," Bow commented with a slight frown on the screen.

Adora chuckled at that - her friend was right. And Glimmer was just worried too much about him. Although, Adora added to herself, her smile fading, the things they had seen happening on Earth were terrible. How could people do this? Most of it made absolutely no sense. And she still felt guilty about it.

At least, they could do something about it now. Something to comfort people and show them that they didn't need to be afraid

any more. She nodded. Yes, they would make things better.

"You've got that expression again," Catra muttered. "I bet you just had a stupid idea."

"No!" Adora defended herself. "It's not a stupid idea," she added with a frown. Now everyone was looking at her. She raised her chin. "I just think we should help Earth recover from this - make up for all the chaos."

"That wasn't our fault!" Glimmer and Catra said in unison, then stared at each other.

"It wasn't," Adora said, even though she wasn't sure. "But we still can and should help."

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta beamed. "I've got some ideas about rebuilding!"

Adora suddenly had second thoughts about her idea.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, August 15th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Bow!"

"Hey!"

Adora watched with a smile as Glimmer tackled Bow before he could clear the ramp of the shuttle.

Next to her, Catra snorted. "He wasn't really in danger," she muttered.

Adora sighed. She agreed with Catra's, but Glimmer had a different opinion. And Adora could understand that - to see the violence and panic their presence had caused… She looked through the window at the blue planet below them. And now the people on Earth were panicking again, even though they hadn't

brought the whole Third Fleet, just an escort of half a dozen frigates - the minimum number that Priest had accepted.

Bow and Glimmer finished their kiss and pulled apart again. He coughed. “Don’t you have to address Earth? To ask for permission to land in Geneva?”

Glimmer pouted at him. “I needed to make sure that you were safe first.”

Catra snorted under her breath - Adora was sure she was the only one to hear it.

“And we can offer our help rebuilding what was destroyed because of our arrival,” Entrapta chimed in.

“That wasn’t our fault,” Hordak said at the same moment Glimmer blurted out: “That’s not our fault!”

Both looked at each other for a moment while Adora suppressed a smile at the sight.

“Anyway,” Glimmer went on, “Let’s address Earth.”

“Right.”

Two minutes later, Glimmer sat in the Captain’s Chair, with Adora and the others standing at her side. It was quite a nice sight if Adora said so herself. Formal, but not too formal. It wasn’t a throne, after all.

“So…” Entrapta stood from where she had been fiddling with the console. “We should be able to connect to the Earth communication networks. We tested the protocols for the television broadcasts.”

“Uh… we aren’t taking over their television, are we?” Adora asked. That would cause more trouble, she was sure.

“No, no - we’re using the radio frequencies. But we’re also using one of the emergency channels to broadcast the video feed from Darla. So, since they’re not using that channel, we’re kinda taking it over and still not taking over television.” Entrapta shrugged. “It should be fine. Anyway, we’re ready to go!” She beamed and walked over to stand in front of Hordak, her hair twitching a little.

Glimmer cleared her throat. “Alright, start broadcasting.”

Adora smiled as widely as she could. They had to make a good impression. They couldn’t cause more panic.

“We’re on!”

“People of Earth! We are representatives of the Princess Alliance of the planet Etheria. I am Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon.” She nodded to the side.

That was Adora’s Cue. She straightened and raised her chin. “I am Adora. I’m also known as She-Ra, Princess of Power.”

“And I’m Entrapta, Princess of Dryl!” Entrapta beamed at the Camera.

“Hordak.” He didn’t bother smiling, Adora noticed.

“My science buddy!”

That, apparently, made Hordak smile. It wasn’t a good smile.

“Catra.” Catra’s smile was more of a smirk.

“And I am Bow.” Bow, though, smiled widely. “Techmaster.”

Melog opened its mouth, and Catra translated: “And this is Melog.”

Glimmer spoke up again. “We’ve met a team of your soldiers when they were stranded on Etheria and brought them back to Earth. And we wish to speak to your United Nations to discuss an alliance against the Goa’uld. They are an enemy of every

civilisation and will not rest until they have crushed everyone else. They hold entire planets in bondage, with countless people, mostly humans from Earth, having been enslaved.

"We will fight them as we fought Horde Prime, to save everyone, but we need your help to do this - everyone's help. So, we ask the rulers of Switzerland for permission to land in Geneva to address the United Nations there." After a moment, she added: "Please let us know on this frequency if we can land there tomorrow."

"And.. cut!" Entrapta smiled. "That went well!" She tilted her head. "I think so, at least."

Bow stepped forward and pushed a few buttons, splitting the big screen to display various television channels.

"...no comment yet from the Swiss government. They seem surprised at this declaration and request…"

"...the Secretary-General of the United Nations released a statement that he would be honoured to welcome the delegation from Etheria at the Palais des Nations in Geneva…"

"...French President stated that he would attend the meeting in Geneva…"

"...Bundeskanzler erklärte, der erste Kontakt mit einer ausserirdischen Zivilisation sei Sache der Vereinten Nationen, und daher…"

"...Russia voiced concerns about the fact that soldiers made contact with Etheria, not diplomats, and once more condemned the secrecy of the United States about their Stargate Program, which has been…"

"...protests are gathering in front of the United Nations Office in New York…"

"...the government of Geneva has formally asked for help from the Federal government and the other cantons to guarantee the

security of the upcoming First Contact…"

"...and as dozens, hundreds of cars leave Geneva, even more try to enter, clogging the streets…"

Glimmer frowned. "Did we get permission to land there yet?"

"No," Bow said. "But it seems that everyone assumes that's merely a formality."

Adora stared at the pictures of vehicles filling the streets.

Catra snorted. "Looks like yesterday."

Adora winced. It did look like yesterday's panic. But… "More people want to see us than are afraid of us?"

Catra snorted again. "That's progress of sorts. Like Kyle only losing half the food he's fetching."

Adora had to laugh at the memories that brought up. But she sobered up almost instantly. "We need to convince them that we don't mean any harm to them."

"Good luck with that," Catra said.

*****

NATO Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, August 15th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and how much advanced technology is being fielded by Stargate Command at this point?" the Ministre de la Défense asked in his slight French accent.

Samantha Carter heard the Colonel mutter something about letting the French sit at the table even though they weren't a full member of NATO but she ignored that and smiled politely. "We regularly field several advanced small arms which have been recovered from the Goa'uld."

"And irregularly?"

"In times of emergency, we will use whatever is at hand, but alien technology isn't standard issue for Stargate Command," the Colonel cut in.

"And what is in development?" the German minister asked. "Surely you're working hard on developing advanced weapons for domestic production."

Of course they were. Sam tilted her head. "As far as I know, no project has reached the point of field testing, much less mass production."

The man leaned forward. "And what sorts of projects do you know of? And how fast could they enter mass production?"

Now that was a tricky question. SG-1 had been ordered to be as open as possible without 'endangering national security'. That was a very flexible term. "I am not part of those research groups," Sam replied. "I am a member of a field unit and a specialist for gate technology, not a weapon developer." Fortunately, the Colonel didn't make any comment about sandbagging. "I couldn't say how far such projects are."

"Really?" The British Secretary of State for Defence frowned. "You are the foremost expert for advanced technology - you were involved in the recovery of most samples of alien weapons the United States currently research, weren't you?"

Sam managed not to wince. Someone must have talked to the Brits. That wasn't the kind of recognition she wanted. "Yes, Sir, but I am working at the front, so to speak, and mainly with the Stargate, not with applied weapon research. I'm a physicist."

"I see that the United States still keep their secrets," the French minister commented with a slight sneer at the Secretary of Defense, who returned it with interest.

"As do we all," the Secretary General interjected. "But we requested SG-1, not their research teams, because we wanted them to share their information about the Etherians. Questions about the state of the American weapons programs seem to be slightly beyond the purpose of this meeting."

Daniel nodded earnestly at that. Most ministers present didn't seem to share that view, though the Minister from Norway seemed to agree as well. "Indeed. Unless the United States are about to deploy spaceships in Earth's defence, knowing as much as possible about the aliens is of much more importance. So, Dr Jackson, you are Stargate's expert for alien cultures.

"Yes, Sir," Daniel replied as if the assembled ministers weren't already aware of that.

"And according to what we were told, you think that the Etherians are honest in their claims. They want an alliance, not subjugation."

"Yes, Minister." Daniel nodded again. "They are an alliance of multiple kingdoms, so they are used to working together against a common enemy without requiring closer ties or control."

"And yet," the French minister spoke up again, "you also said they were shocked about certain discriminatory policies common on Earth. You even called those policies the biggest hurdle for an alliance."

"Yes," Daniel replied without hesitation. "It's all in my report. Since on Etheria, politics is a highly personal affair, their rulers are much more concerned about such discrimination than we're used to on Earth."

"Do you think that they will be willing to ignore certain peculiarities in order to focus on our common enemy?"

Daniel's wince told them enough. And if that hadn't been a big clue, the Secretary of Defense's glare would have clinched it. "I

am not certain, of course - they can be pragmatic - but I doubt that."

"I see." The French minister leaned back with a slight smirk.

"What about 'magic'? the British Secretary of State for Defence asked. "You mentioned that they are planning to 'restore magic to Earth'. Could you elaborate on this?"

Sam fought the urge to wince again. Another landmine that Daniel wouldn't hesitate to step on. Some generals would want SG-1 posted in Alaska after this.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, August 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So… we're clear to land in Geneva. The Swiss government apologised for the delay in responding," Bow told them as Adora and Catra stepped on Darla's bridge. "Apparently, the airport was swamped with planes from all over the world, and it took a while to clear the airspace."

"I don't know why they would do that. Darla is perfectly capable of hovering until we can land. There was no need to reroute or delay any planes," Entrapta said.

"I think there were also security concerns," Hordak said.

"Darla's got shields," Entrapta retorted.

"Yes. We should be more concerned about an attack on the ground," Catra commented as she leaned against Adora's chair. She didn't quite trust everyone on Earth. For a supposedly neutral, peaceful country, the Swiss had a lot of soldiers.

"Yes," Glimmer agreed with a frown. "Entrapta, you need to keep an eye out for any threats."

“Will do!” Entrapta nodded. “I’ve adapted the Scanner to cover most weapons on Earth.”

“‘Most’?” Glimmer asked.

“I had to exclude swords and knives - there were too many in every plane, for example.”

“I didn’t think that they were using swords on Earth,” Adora said. “They were surprised by mine.”

“It was mostly knives. I could fine-tune the Scanners to ignore smaller blades, but according to that show we saw, even small blades can be deadly.”

“I think we can handle an attacker using knives,” Bow said. “Should the Swiss guards not be able to handle them.”

“Yes! So, now let’s land and show the people of Earth that we come to help them and that they don’t have to fear us,” Adora said with a smile.

“As long as they don’t mean us any harm,” Catra commented as she flexed her claws. At Adora’s frown, she added: “I’m just saying I’m not going to let anyone hurt us.” Especially not Adora.

Glimmer nodded in agreement as Darla started to descend into Earth’s atmosphere.

*****

The United Nations

Geneva Airport, Switzerland, August 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Alright… they want us to land there!"

Catra looked at the spot Adora indicated. It was right in front of what seemed to be the main building. And lots of people were lined up nearby, held back by flimsy-looking barriers.

But they were already descending. She looked at Entrapta. "Any threats?"

"Uh… the soldiers are armed, but they should be armed. Although the ones standing in a line there aren't armed - their weapons aren't loaded. But the ones on the roofs and around us are armed. But there's nothing that would threaten Darla."

"And us?" Catra asked. She wasn't really worried about Darla.

"Hm… we could take a portable shield generator just in case?"

"Yes," Catra agreed before anyone else could say anything. "And we've got Melog."

Yes. Safe.

"They say it's safe."

"Good. Now let's land. Preferably without crushing the welcome committee," Glimmer said. She was wearing a fancier version of her normal clothes - her 'coronation outfit', Adora and Bow, who were both wearing their Princess Prom outfits, had called it.

Well, Catra's suit hadn't survived the war, but her regular clothes would do. It wasn't as if Entrapta was dressing up at all.

Adora chuckled, but she sounded a little nervous - the space was a little tight, Catra noticed.

But the ship touched down just fine between the large building and the small round buildings that seemed to connect to the planes.

Adora stood and took a deep breath. “Alright. Let’s be on our best behaviour!” She looked at Catra.

Catra smirked back at her. “I’m always on my best behaviour.”

“Just don’t…” Adora sighed. “Don’t scare them.”

Catra put her hand on her chest. “Me? What about Glimmer.”

“I’m not going to scare them!” Glimmer protested at once, as Catra had expected.

“Let’s just go and don’t scare anyone,” Bow said. He smoothed his top and brushed some imaginary speck of dust from his belt, Catra noticed - he wasn’t as calm as he tried to act.

They let the ramp down and stepped out. The white-haired man in the middle of the group waiting for them took a step forward and smiled. Behind him, the soldiers tensed and straightened. Just like in the Horde, Catra thought and suppressed a snarl.

Adora tensed as well, she knew, and she ran the tip of her tail over the back of Adora’s thigh. A soft giggle told her that it had worked.

Then they reached the bottom of the ramp, Glimmer in the lead, and the white-haired man - apparently the leader of the Swiss, their ‘Bundespräsident’ - offered a handshake. “Your Royal Highness, we’re honoured to welcome you to Switzerland for this historic occasion! I’m the President of the Swiss Confederation. ”

Glimmer slowly inclined her head and returned the greeting. “We’re honoured to be here.”

Then the music started.

“As you told us that you don’t have a national anthem, we’ve picked the Hymn to the United Nations,” the man explained. He had a different accent than O’Neill’s team, Catra noticed.

“It’s alright,” Adora said with a smile.

“Is that like The Internationale?” Entrapta asked.

“Ah…” the president’s smile froze for a moment. “Not quite.” And he was back to smiling widely.

Then they reached the end of the formation of soldiers - who didn’t look very impressive compared to SG-1, to Catra at least - and the president introduced the rest of the Swiss government, who had all shown up to greet them. Apparently, that was quite unusual. Not that Catra cared about that - they weren’t here for the Swiss, but for the United Nations.

But everyone was here for them. She saw countless cameras and other sensors aimed at them. And banners and flowers. The crowd was getting a little unruly, in her opinion. And a lot of attention seemed to be aimed at her - and at Melog and Hordak.

Right, she reminded herself. Those people were only used to humans like Adora. She grinned at the thought that, for once, she was drawing more attention than Glimmer or Adora. Though, to be fair, Adora wasn’t in her She-Ra form.

Then came the speeches. The Swiss president gave a short speech that basically repeated what he had told them. Switzerland was happy and honoured to have them here. Glimmer told them that they were happy and honoured to be here.

Catra wasn’t. It was pretty hot, and the crowd was very loud. And she felt exposed - so many people, and she had no idea how many of them hated her.

Fortunately, after Glimmer's speech, they moved inside for a quick 'apéro', which apparently was a Swiss custom that involved drinking wine and eating tiny food while chatting. Or, in her case, watching how Entrapta confused the older Swiss who was talking to her by delivering detailed explanations about Darla's engines as soon as he mentioned the ship. Or somehow seemed to disturb the people from Earth by using her hair to grab the tiny food and stuff it into her mouth with obvious enthusiasm.

"Catra," Adora hissed next to her, picking another tiny bread with sausage from a plate. "Be more polite."

"I am being polite," she replied in a low voice. "I haven't insulted anyone." Or clawed anyone.

"I mean, mingle a bit with them! You scared away the one man who tried to talk to you."

"I didn't! He was allergic to my fur."

"What?"

"That's what he said."

"But…" Adora sighed.

Catra grinned. The man had gotten off lightly, anyway - he had asked if her 'ancestors' had ever visited Earth before because, apparently, some ancient people on Earth had worn cat pelts or something.

At least the fish sandwiches were great - she had to get more of that 'salmon' stuff. Perhaps if she acted offended, they'd offer her a load as an apology?

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, August 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“The Etherians are moving,” an aide reported to the President. “Their car has already left the airport.”

“Finally,” Jack O’Neill muttered under his breath as the President turned to the Secretary of State for some more last-minute talk. The Swiss had kept the Etherians for almost an hour. “What took them so long? Everyone’s waiting!

“Well, as the host country, they probably felt it wouldn’t be dignified if they just, ah, waved them through,” Daniel suggested, looking up from his notebook. “But they probably also thought this was a great opportunity to network or something.”

“Probably tried to get them to deposit their money in Swiss banks.” Jack scoffed. “They aren’t even in the United Nations!”

“They claim that their neutrality forbids it.” Daniel shrugged. “But there are proposals being discussed for Switzerland to join the United Nations, I believe.” Then he frowned. “However, you raise a good point. If an alliance is made, probably even without a formal alliance, we’ll have to regulate trade, which will involve money.”

“Great. Let’s hope that we get to watch when the Swiss get nuked from orbit for trying to help Etherians evade taxation.” Jack snorted.

“I believe trade contact will be limited to princesses, at least at first, so tax evasion shouldn’t be a concern since the princesses basically tax themselves,” Daniel replied. “Although private enterprises might also enter this on the Etherian side, I’m not actually sure how much of the Etherian economy would be compatible with such a system. Most of the enterprises rely on royal charters, as far as I know.”

Jack was about to tell Daniel that he had been joking, but they had attracted the attention of the Secretary of Defense. “We will need an analysis of the impact of trade agreements with Etheria

on their and our economy. If we can leverage our economic strength…"

Daniel actually winced. "Ah… I don't know enough about economics to do that."

"We have experts for that. We need your knowledge about their planet and society."

"I can do that, I think," Daniel said. "But I have to reiterate that the Etherians aren't primitive. They may lack industrialisation, but they have advanced technology and an extensive trade network that can handle magic powers which, for example, allow near-unlimited agricultural produce."

That, Jack saw, gave the Secretary of Defense pause. "You mean that if they get unlimited access to our markets, our farmers will crucify us."

Daniel inclined his head. "I can't speak for them, of course, but I would advise being cautious when approaching trade agreements."

"Yes. Let's focus on the military question."

"The Etherians are here!" another aide announced.

"And did they receive our request for a short meeting so we can apologise for the lapse in security at Area-51?" the President asked.

"Yes, Mr President."

"Good."

"Didn't we do that already?" Daniel asked in a low voice.

"It's just an excuse to meet with the gang before the big speeches," Jack explained.

"Oh."

And then the Etherians entered the room. Glimmer and Bow in front, followed by Adora and Catra, and then Entrapta and Hordak. Jack pressed his lips together - he really didn't like seeing the former warlord here. All dressed… Well, Adora, Bow and Glimmer had dressed up, but the others wore their usual clothes. Daniel would probably know what that said about them.

"Ah, Your Royal Highness," the President smiled at her, displaying the same charm that had won him the election.

"Queen Glimmer, Mr President," Glimmer replied," if you want to be formal."

"Right. Different planets." The President nodded. "So, I would like once more to apologise for the incident at Area 51. We were surprised by the events."

"Thank you," Glimmer said, nodding.

"Nothing happened," Bow added with a smile. "And it wasn't your fault."

That, Jack noticed, drew some frowns from Glimmer and Hordak, but neither of them spoke up.

And the President smoothly went on: "Fortunately, nothing happened. None of the protesters got close to the actual base - we actually had to save a few who managed to get lost in the desert."

"Ah. As long as no one was killed or seriously hurt," Adora said with a smile that looked a little forced to Jack. So, she was feeling guilty.

"I trust that your security procedures will be improved in the future," Hordak spoke up. "A group of mostly unarmed and unorganised assailants shouldn't be able to come near a crucial testing facility."

“Well, they actually didn’t - they merely breached the outermost perimeter,” the President replied. “But we are indeed reviewing security, I can assure you.”

“Thank you,” Glimmer said with a glance at the alien warlord.

“So, did you enjoy the reception by the Swiss?”

“The apéro? Yes,” Glimmer said.

“Except for the weird man who wanted to talk about cat people,” Catra interjected.

“A member of the Swiss government?” the President asked.

“An advisor,” Adora explained. “And they apologised for it. With salmon,” she added with a glance at Catra, who flashed her teeth with a wide grin.

Everyone chuckled at that. Even Jack - it seemed that the Swiss had made a gaffe.

“So, it seems that, once more, no harm was done,” the President spoke up again. “So, it’s time for us, I think to take our seats in the assembly. We’ll leave SG-1 to keep you company while you wait for your grand entrance.”

And Jack was once more reminded why he didn’t like politicians.

*****

The Assembly Hall looked very impressive but not quite as large - or tall - as the Great Hall in Bright Moon. Or the hall Frosta had had prepared for the Princess Prom. Still, it was much bigger than the room used for the President’s Press Conference, Adora noted as they entered. It was also full - every seat was occupied. And everyone was staring at her and her friends.

Well, she had faced worse. Probably - armies counted, didn’t they? In any case, they were here to make a good impression,

and that was what they would do. She straightened, raising her chin, and kept smiling.

She wouldn't have to give a speech, anyway - that was Glimmer's job. She followed her friend on the stage, where the Secretary-General of the United Nations was waiting. He looked very dignified and friendly, like he could be Bow's grandfather. And… Well, she didn't want to think ill of their friends, but the Secretary-General looked more honest than the President. His smile certainly seemed more genuine as he shook their hands.

"Queen Glimmer, Princess Adora, Princess Entrapta, Mister Bow, Miss Catra, Mister Hordak, welcome to Earth. The United Nations are honoured to meet you."

No dig against the USA, Adora noted, as the Secretary-General held a little speech about the United Nations representing Earth and the shared desire for peace. Well, maybe there was - it could be a cultural thing she was missing. As Bow said, different cultures had different ways to be subtle.

Lots of applause followed the end of the man's speech. Then it was Glimmer's turn. Adora's friend didn't look nervous at all as she stepped up to the small pedestal, staff field firmly in hand. She looked determined. As if this was a battle to be won.

Adora suppressed a wince. Sometimes, Glimmer overdid it.

"People of Earth!" Glimmer began, "I bring greetings from the planet Etheria. As you may know already, I am Queen Glimmer, and I represent the Princess Alliance of Etheria. We come in peace and offer our friendship and aid. We are saddened that news of our arrival caused so much panic and destruction on Earth and offer our sincere regrets - and our hope that we shall overcome this and won't let those tragic events stand in the way of a close friendship between our worlds."

Adora nodded. They should have handled that better, even though she didn't know how they could've done that. Not without

delaying the entire war effort and lying - at least by omission - to Earth.

"However, as Etheria found out, to our chagrin, in the recent past, not everyone in the galaxy desires peace and friendship. As you were told, the Goa'uld desire to rule the entire galaxy and have enslaved countless people - many of them from Earth. They have attacked other planets in the past and twice tried to conquer Earth in recent years. Etheria, too, has faced such attacks. Less than one year ago, our planet was attacked by a brutal enemy, Horde Prime. He had enslaved and even destroyed many planets, but the Princess Alliance defeated him and liberated his enslaved soldiers."

Adora nodded again, her smile gone as she remembered that struggle. She had almost lost Catra. It hurt just to think of that moment when she had seen her friend, her love, speak with that horrible fake voice, smile in that…

A hand slipped into hers, squeezing gently, and Adora smiled again. They had beaten Horde Prime. She had defeated him and saved everyone. Including Catra. She smiled at her.

Glimmer, meanwhile, went on: "And our experience fighting for our freedom against ruthless tyrants is what compels us to offer our help to Earth. We will not let another planet suffer the fate Etheria barely avoided."

Once more, Adora nodded with a firm expression. The Goa'uld wouldn't conquer or destroy Earth. They wouldn't let them.

"But the Goa'uld already occupy and oppress many planets whose people deserve better. We have to help them as well, and for that, we need help - from Earth. Therefore, we ask for an alliance with those on Earth who are willing to reach out and help others even if it means war. Millions of enslaved people need us - need you - to step up and face the Goa'uld. We won't have peace until those enemies are defeated and their slaves freed. And we've come to

Earth to lay the foundation for that. Together, we can save the galaxy!”

Glimmer nodded and took a step back from the pedestal as the people applauded. Some were enthusiastic, some not so - at least it looked like that to Adora - but that was to be expected. It was actually better if the United Nations weren’t too eager to wage war, in her opinion.

The Secretary-General smiled again at Glimmer and then opened the floor, as he called it, for questions from the audience.

And they did have questions. Lots of questions. Adora blinked at the number of questions. Some were quite reasonable. Some were not so reasonable. And some were… weird.

*****

“No, we aren’t planning to intervene in any local conflicts,” Glimmer said. “We want an alliance against the Goa’uld, our common enemy, not an alliance against people on Earth.”

The representative - from a country currently waging a civil war - didn’t look satisfied. Well, we’ve expected that, Samantha Carter thought from her seat at the side of the stage as the Assembly questioned the Etherians. Everyone needed to know as much as possible to make informed decisions, after all.

“What is your marital status?” That question came from a country ruled by a monarch - one with multiple wives. Sam wondered if Glimmer was aware of that.

Glimmer looked surprised - as did her friends. “What would that matter? I’m in a happy relationship.”

“And so am I!” Entrapta announced. “If you wanted to know!”

Sam saw Catra grab Adora’s arm and lean her head against her shoulder.

“Will you demand that your soldiers are exempt from local laws?”

The Colonel grumbled about that obvious reference to US policy.

“No,” Glimmer said. “Although we will not ally with any country where we would need such protection from the laws.”

Daniel nodded. “That’s nicely worded.”

Sam had expected someone to ask for clarifications, but the next question changed the subject.

“Will you share your technology with your allies?”

“Yes,” Glimmer said, “we are looking for a real alliance - including the exchange of technology. It would be stupid to wage war without sharing technology when we are facing a common enemy. However, we also know about the risks of helping people in need, only for them to turn on us.”

Sam didn’t miss the glance Glimmer sent at Hordak when she said that.

Another representative was called to ask a question. “We have heard similar promises in the past. What assurances can you give us that you aren’t going to colonise us?”

Glimmer blinked and looked at the Secretary-General. A quick whispering exchange followed before the woman nodded, though she still looked confused. “Why would we want to conquer you? We just fought a war to defeat Horde Prime, who tried to conquer us.”

“You could be trying to deceive us. You said you need us to fight this war for you, ostensibly to protect us. We’ve heard that before.”

“Well, it’s the truth. We have plenty of ships, but you can’t really take a planet with just ships, not without wrecking the ecosphere in the process, and you can’t hold a planet,” Glimmer explained.

“Troops from Earth would be ideal to occupy Goa’uld planets and deliver help to the population. You have so many of them.”

Sam winced even before several representatives started badgering Glimmer with more pointed questions.

“Yeah, that struck a nerve with many former colonies,” the Colonel commented in a low voice. “Betcha that there’ll be cartoons depicting Glimmer as a new Queen Victoria trying to rule the world.”

He had a point, in Sam’s opinion.

“We probably gave the Etherians a not entirely correct impression of Earth’s stance towards war,” Daniel said.

That, too, sounded plausible.

“Hey!” Glimmer said, raising her hands as the Secretary-General finally managed to calm the Assembly down again. “I’m telling the truth. I’m not trying to deceive anyone. We need each other if we want to save all those people.”

“Will you share your technology even if we don’t want to fight for you?”

Glimmer, once again, looked surprised, then frowned. “You wouldn’t be fighting for us, but for Earth and everyone else in the galaxy. Also, if you aren’t willing to help others, why do you expect help from others?”

Adora took a step forward. “We will help you if you need help,” she said, her voice carrying through the Assembly. “But we will not just hand out technology that you can use to oppress others. We’ve seen how that works.”

“What about technology to improve the standards of living?”

“What about technology to combat famines?”

“Will you share advanced medicine?”

The Etherians seemed surprised and looked at each other. And then Entrapta spoke up, her hair lifting her up to the better look over the desk: “Well, according to the data we gathered, you have all the technology and infrastructure to feed and treat everyone, but you don’t for some reason. We would first need to know why you don’t do that in order to see how we can help there.” She nodded. “If it’s a lack of magic, that should be remedied as soon as Adora unlocks Earth’s magic.”

Sam winced at the storm of questions and yelling that unleashed. It took several minutes for the Secretary-General to calm the Assembly down again this time.

“That’ll kill the relations with a lot of countries,” the Colonel commented.

“Yes, magic,” Entrapta explained. “Much of Etherian’s native technology is based on magic - especially for medicine. Though,” she perked up, “we have made strides in cybernetics as well, you prefer to replace rather than heal damaged limbs, for example!” Bow whispered something to her, and she frowned. “Anyway, Earth’s magic, like the magic for most of the galaxy, is currently blocked, but Adora can unblock it. Once she does, you’ll be able to use magic.”

Several representatives loudly opposed this plan, and the Assembly descended into chaos yet again.

The Etherians looked confused and even shocked for a moment. But as the chaos continued, Adora suddenly frowned, then took a step forward. She raised her arm, and her sword appeared in it, pointed towards the ceiling.

“Oh, no!” the Colonel spat.

“For the Honour of Grayskull!”

Sam looked away as blinding light enveloped Adora for a moment, and she transformed.

Then She-Ra was standing there on the stage, still frowning at the suddenly quiet Assembly. “I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. I’m not here to conquer anyone. I’m here to help you. Magic was taken from Earth long ago. I’m here to restore it to your world - if you want me to.” She lowered her sword. “Magic is not evil. It can do a lot of good. It can heal. It can restore destroyed lands and improve and save your lives. And it’s your birthright.”

“That struck a nerve as well,” Daniel commented as the assembled diplomats erupted in yelling again.

*****

“Hrrngh!”

Glimmer looked tenser than after a battle, Catra noticed when they’d finally left the Assembly Hall and ‘retired’ to a private room with a big table and comfortable chairs. She wasn’t quite gnashing her teeth, but you could almost feel the frustration radiating from her. And the desire to do some violence.

“What’s wrong with them?” Glimmer spat as she sank into a chair at the head of the table. “We told them everything they wanted to know, and they still don’t trust us!”

“They think we could be lying,” Bow said, moving to the small fridge in the corner.

“But that makes no sense.” Entrapta frowned. “Even with just the ships in orbit, we’re strong enough to conquer Earth.”

“Telling them that made things worse.” Adora sighed and laid down her head on the table for a moment. Then she suddenly seemed to remember that they weren’t at home and sat up straight.

Catra chuckled at the sight and moved to stand behind her, rubbing her shoulders.

"They are very irrational," Hordak commented. "Although they might think we are trying to deceive them and do not have the force to conquer them. Maybe a demonstration would correct that misconception."

Catra shook her head as Glimmer and Adora glared at Hordak. Her former leader still didn't fully understand people. Just like Entrapta.

"We are not going to 'demonstrate' an orbital bombardment," Glimmer spat. "We're here to form an alliance, not to conquer a planet. Or colonise them. We're not imperialists!"

"Someone's learned a few new words today!" Catra said, snorting.

Glimmer glared at her, and Adora frowned, but that was to be expected.

"Oh, lighten up," Catra said, sliding into Adora's lap. "They're bound to distrust us. How would we react if a fleet arrived out of nowhere and wanted to help us fight another Horde Prime?"

Adora stopped shifting around under Catra and said: "We offered our help when SG-1 arrived on Etheria."

"They were four people and needed help. They weren't a fleet," Bow pointed out as he placed several bottles of drinks on the table.

"Oh! Soda!" Entrapta grabbed two of them with her hair and handed a third to Hordak. "That's from that show we saw!"

"That was advertising," Glimmer told her. "And yes, I completely understand that they might be cautious." Catra cleared her throat, about to mention Glimmer's earlier words, but the princess went on: "But they think the worst of us! And their questions were very rude!"

“Were they?” Entrapta asked, blinking, between sipping from two different sodas.

“Yes,” Glimmer said.

“You generally don’t ask after someone’s relationships in such a meeting,” Bow explained. “That’s a private matter.”

“Even when it’s two princesses?” Entrapta asked.

“Well… we’re not,” Glimmer replied. “But that’s not what I meant. The way some of them asked after our technology…” She shook her head.

“And magic,” Bow said.

Glimmer groaned. “Don’t remind me. You’d think we threatened them with extinction when we offered to restore magic.”

“Not all of them reacted like that,” Adora said, one arm tightening around Catra’s waist. “A few were very positive. Well, they were interested,” she added.

“Because they probably think that as soon as you unlock the magic of Earth, they’ll have princesses and sorcerers,” Catra said, leaning her head back against Adora’s shoulder.

“Why would they think that?” Entrapta shook her head. “It’s obvious that they will need to study magic and learn how to wield it before they can achieve anything. And we don’t even know if they have dormant princesses.”

“It’s not obvious,” Bow told her. “They probably think it’s easy to use.”

“Their TV shows certainly gave that impression,” Glimmer said, slumping a little. “Snip your fingers and do magic.” She scoffed.

“Well, we have to correct that misunderstanding,” Adora said. “We need to talk to them again. The more they know, the more they’ll

trust us."

"More shouting at each other?" Catra snorted.

"I mean private meetings, of course," Adora retorted. "Before the actual negotiations."

"Then we'll get accused of hiding secrets." Catra shrugged. "Not that that can be helped, I guess."

Adora was about to say something - probably another optimistic thing - but a knock at the door interrupted her before she could start.

"Yes?" Glimmer spoke up.

The door opened, and the Secretary-General entered. "I'm sorry, I was held up by some insistent delegates." He smiled. "They had some concerns about today's revelations."

"We're not going to conquer Earth," Glimmer said.

"Though we have the capability," Hordak added.

"Actually," the man told them, "most of the concerns were related to magic."

"Really?" Adora blinked.

Catra frowned. Those people were actually more concerned about magic than about the war with the Goa'uld?

The old man nodded. "Magic is a controversial topic for many religions."

"Daniel mentioned something like that," Adora said with a deep frown. "But we're not going to force anyone to use magic if they don't want to."

The smile on the Secretary-General's face slipped a little. "They are concerned about others being able to use magic."

“Why would that concern them?” Glimmer asked. “Are they afraid that a princess will conquer their country?”

“Without runestones to boost magic powers, that is very, very unlikely given your level of technology,” Entrapta said. “I would say impossible, but there’s always the theoretical possibility of an incredible outlier.”

“As I said, it’s based on religion,” the Secretary-General told them.

“You mean it’s irrational,” Hordak said.

“In a way, yes,” the man replied. “Although since, apparently, magic is real and was common on Earth in the past, many such preconceptions might have to be reevaluated.” He sighed. “The revelation that malevolent aliens posed as gods in the past hasn’t helped, of course. Many religious people are very… concerned about the ramifications of this.”

“So, they need more data to process this?” Entrapta asked. “We can help with that!” She beamed at the man.

Looking at the man’s polite smile, Catra somehow had the impression that things wouldn’t be as easy as Entrapta thought.

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Hotel Intercontinental, Geneva, Switzerland, August 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“Quite nice digs,” Jack O’Neill commented when he stepped into SG-1’s - minus Teal’c, who was still stuck at Stargate Command - temporary quarters. A room in a luxury hotel surely beat the usual bachelor’s quarters on a base. Hell, it beat his home. Well, as long as they had room service that served beer.

“We’re on the same floor as the President,” Daniel said, looking at the two beds. “Which one do you want?”

“Pick one,” Jack told him as he looked for the remote. He knocked on the door to the next room. “Carter?”

The door opened, and Carter appeared. “Sir?”

“Everything alright, Carter?” Jack asked. There! He grabbed the remote from the sideboard and switched the TV on.

“Yes, Sir.”

“Now, let’s see how the world’s reacting to the arrival of our new friends,” Jack said.

“...Queen Glimmer, representing the Princess Alliance of Etheria, gave a speech in the Assembly Hall of the United Nations building in Geneva where she promised help against the Goa’uld threat and offered to share the advanced technology if Earth joined the war. Our analysts predict…”

“...Wallstreet is in an uproar. The stock market is oscillating - investors cannot seem to make up their minds whether or not the news about aliens are good news. Even shares in military corporations, which have jumped in price since the shocking reveal by the US government, have suffered losses today as analysts profess doubts that all of them will benefit equally from shared alien technology…”

“...als Vertreter von Rheinmetall führte aus, dass nun dringender Handlungsbedarf bestehe. Die Gesetze, die die Ausfuhr von Rüstungsgütern kontrollieren, würden die Sicherheit Deutschlands und der Welt gefährden, und er forderte…”

“...protests against the war with the Goa’uld have been announced all across the world, with varying attendance so far. In some cases, violent confrontations with protesters who call for immediate action to free humans enslaved by aliens have claimed several victims…”

“... so we ask: Who is this ‘Queen Glimmer’, and why should we care what she wants? So far, we haven’t seen any proof that Earth

is in danger - we have only the word of the United States Government, which has admitted to having lied to the world for years, and the word of aliens who openly want mercenaries for their war for this. I call for…"

"...the Swiss police is out in force to keep protesters from reaching the Palais des Nations. Several clashes have resulted in entire streets being cordoned off and the arrests of hundreds of people."

"...in a blatant powerplay, the aliens offer technology for soldiers for their war…"

"...China has refused to comment on the situation and continues to exert the strictest control over all media in the country since 1989…"

"...has voiced concerns about another attempt at colonisation…"

"...released a statement that calls for immediate action against the Goa'uld and stronger powers for the United Nations. As she was quoted, 'if there ever was a time for Earth to unite, then this is the time. Faced with a war in space and alien allies, we have to speak with one voice for the betterment of humanity as a whole."

"...asked about the stance of the Catholic Church on magic, the Vatican declined to comment, announcing that such a question required careful consideration, and…"

"...renowned scholar at the Al-Azhar Mosque in Cairo, stated that the Qoran doesn't condemn magic as a whole but only certain practises of it. Yet several imams have already denounced the Etherians as enemies of the Faith and called upon…"

"...was quoted as saying that 'the Bible clearly condemns both witchcraft and homosexuality' and called upon the immediate cessation of diplomatic contacts with the aliens in order to 'save the American people from eternal damnation'."

"Russia's president announced a national state of heightened alert and stated that the government was looking at emergency

measures to prepare the country for a possible war. He didn't specify which war, nor did he react to questions about rumours of Russia defaulting on…"

"...Japan's Prime Minister is about to meet with several Shinto priests to discuss the subject of magic…"

"...Her Majesty, Queen Elizabeth II of England, denied that there were any plans to propose a dynastic marriage between one of her grandchildren and a princess of Etheria."

Jack took a deep breath. He really should have expected that. "So… that happened."

"It could've been worse?" Daniel offered.

Before Jack could ask Carter, who was uncharacteristically silent, their phone rang. Daniel picked up the receiver. "Doctor Jackson." He blinked. "Yes, we're on the way." He looked at Jack and put the receiver down. "We're to attend a briefing in the President's suite."

Great. Jack sighed. "Alright, folks. Let's go."

The suite was just down the hall - past half a dozen suits from the Secret Service. There were more, Jack knew - they had to rent the entire floor on short notice, and no one was happy with the current security. But it was still safer than staying in Airforce One on the tarmac. At least according to the Secret Service.

The President's suite wasn't packed as Jack had expected - the President was there, currently on the phone, as were the Secretary of State and the Secretary of Defense and their aides. And more Secret Service personnel.

The President nodded at them while he paced. "Yes, dear… Yes, that's a good idea… Talk to him again… yes…"

"So!" The Secretary of State smiled, although he looked tired. "That went well."

"Sir?" Jack cocked his head.

"The reaction from the rest of the world," the man clarified. "That should increase our chances to form an alliance between NATO and the Etherians." He shook his head. "That they fixated on magic…"

"Have you seen the reactions from several prominent televangelists?" Daniel asked.

The man waved the argument away. "That's just a bunch of extremists. We can handle them. But the Etherians have now seen that we're amongst the most progressive countries in the world." He smiled again. "This is the opportunity we need."

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, August 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...Russia's president further demanded joint talks between the aliens, NATO, Russia and China, claiming that, in light of the fact that the USA hid the existence of aliens for years, bilateral talks wouldn't be conducive to building the necessary trust for…"

"...China has still not commented on the recent revelations about aliens except to assure its population that the government has the situation in hand. Independent information about the events in China are hard to come by given their total information blackout, but reports claim that several spontaneous protests, even pro-government, have been harshly subdued and…"

"...speculation about the aliens continues to run rampant. An analysis of their body language during the speech in the Assembly Hall of the United Nations indicates romantic entanglements between…"

"...pundits were torn regarding the question of whether or not the aliens favoured same-sex relationships and what that would mean for Earth…"

"...several members of the clergy have already condemned those potential relationships while the church officially is still debating whether or not aliens are part of God's creation…"

"...question of magic, thousands of concerned citizens have been calling their representatives, demanding…"

"...physicist Stephen Hawking released a statement that he was looking forward to observing magic and adjusting his theories accordingly…"

"..in contrast, several 'covens' have filed preemptive complaints that any action by the government aimed at preventing the, I quote 'release of magic' would be a violation of their religious freedom. The government hasn't yet…"

Adora shook her at the rapidly changing screen that Entrapta had rigged up in their room - a conference room - in the Palais des Nations. "Are they really focusing on magic and our relationships?" she asked. "Instead of, like, the war against the Goa'uld?"

"I am not surprised by this irrational behaviour. Not in the slightest," Hordak said.

Catra, Adora saw, rolled her eyes. "Daniel warned us about that, remember?"

"I didn't think it would be that bad," Adora admitted. Why were they so concerned about who other people loved? Or about magic? "They're calling me a witch." She pressed her teeth together. She wasn't a witch! She wasn't like Shadow Weaver! Not in the slightest!

"They're idiots," Catra said. "They know nothing about witches."

"Or princesses," Glimmer added. Adora's friend was angry. "First those questions in the Assembly Hall, and now this! Aren't those people aware that we're fighting a war?"

“They’re questioning that,” Entrapta commented - she was again wearing her mask, hooked up to the TV receiver in the room. “Some people claim it’s all a hoax invented to make people comply with our demands.”

“What demands?”

“Legalise gay marriage, apparently,” Entrapta said. “And corrupt their children. And ‘imperil their immortal souls’ - whatever that means - with ‘fell sorcery’.”

“That’s ridiculous!” Adora spat.

“Actually, we’re indirectly pushing for that,” Bow interjected. “Not for the corruption and endangering, I mean, but we did say we wouldn’t ally with countries where our families would be illegal.”

“That’s not the same!” Adora insisted.

“It kind of is,” Catra retorted. “The technology we can share means that any country that gets it will be much more powerful than those who don’t get it. And people don’t like being powerless,” she added with a tight impression that made Adora want to hug her.

She didn’t do that, though - Catra would be more embarrassed than reassured and probably push her away. And… “Great. So we are pushing our morals on others,” Adora said

“No!” Glimmer objected. “We’re looking for friends who are like us. That’s not the same. And it’s perfectly legitimate.”

“But we need Earth.” Entrapta pushed her mask up. “What do we do if there are no people like us who like us?” She looked worried.

Hordak scoffed. “Based on my analysis of Earth so far, we do not have to worry about that. There will be many countries whose leaders are willing to adapt to become our allies.” He nodded. “As we have seen, many resent the current balance of power on Earth.”

“And we’re upsetting that balance.” Adora sighed again. “What do we do if war breaks out over this?”

“We would crush any enemy. Earth does not have the technology to threaten us,” Hordak said at once.

“I meant between different countries on Earth,” Adora explained.

“There are multiple wars currently being fought on Earth, though they seem to be civil wars - wars between people of the same country,” Entrapta said. “What would one additional war change?”

“A war between powerful countries isn’t the same as the wars here,” Glimmer objected. “They can lay waste to entire countries - even the world - according to Daniel and Sam.”

Adora pressed her lips together. They would have to make sure that this wouldn’t happen. No matter how.

“Oh!” Entrapta sounded surprised. “Some people are calling us magical girls. And speculating whether or not we all have ‘the power to transform’. And they wonder if Catra can change into Melog.”

“What?” “What?”

Adora looked at the screen. It was showing two old men talking at a younger woman about magic and the economy. “Where did you find that?”

“It’s on another part of the communication network,” Entrapta said. “Let me put it on the screen… there!”

The moving pictures were replaced by text. And drawings. Drawings of…

“Cat people?” Catra blurted out. “Why would they have pictures of cat people?”

“Those are called cartoons,” Entrapta explained. “I haven’t found the ones they refer to yet. They seem to be obscure.”

The pictures shown were drawings of cat people. But they didn’t look like Catra. Some didn’t even have a tail!

“Whatever,” Catra spat. “Let’s focus on Earth politics. We can watch cartoons once we’ve dealt with that.”

“Are you sure? This could grant us important insights into how Earth people behave!” Entrapta objected.

Catra glanced at Adora. Well, glared would be more correct.

Adora sighed. “Yes, let’s focus on politics for now.”

They needed to talk to so many people…

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The Negotiations

Hotel Intercontinental, Geneva, Switzerland, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter checked one last time that the encryption on the satellite phone was working, then established the connection. After a moment, the symbol of Stargate Command appeared on her laptop's screen, followed by General Hammond - and Teal'c - in the General's office.

"Good morning, General," the Colonel said at once. "Well, it's morning here in Switzerland."

Sam's body, though, still felt as if it should be night. Jet lag had finally caught up with them.

"Good morning, Colonel. Captain. Doctor Jackson."

Teal'c inclined his head, and that was it.

Hammond narrowed his eyes slightly. "Do you require more data for a report?"

"Ah… we're just touching base, so to speak," the Colonel said. "What with all the hubbub about the aliens, we wanted to check how things are back home."

The General chuckled. "We aren't suffering from civilians trying to storm the base," he said. "And the Stargate has been sealed for the time being."

"Oh?" The Colonel frowned.

"In the current situation, continued operation of the Stargate was deemed unwise. Our best team is off-base, and we're under a lot of scrutiny." Hammon pressed his lips together. "As far as I am aware, the revelations about the truth behind our project ruffled some feathers amongst the staff in NORAD."

Sam frowned. NORAD's commanders had been informed when the project started.

"You mean some staffers aren't happy that they weren't important enough to need to know about Stargate Command?" The Colonel snorted. "I bet Wilkinson is amongst them."

"Wilkinson?" Teal'c asked, tilting his head.

"A particularly arrogant colonel who thought deep-space telemetry was a dead-end for wash-outs," the Colonel explained, baring his teeth. "He was quite open with his opinion."

And would now be lamenting his judgment, Sam thought.

"And how are things on the diplomatic front?"

"Ah, just peachy." The Colonel's smile grew more forced - Sam could tell. "The Etherians discovered the Internet."

"Ah." Hammond closed his eyes for a moment. "And just at the moment that the Internet discovered aliens are real."

"Yes." The Colonel chuckled. "Although, if you're shopping for a Christmas gift for magical princesses, we've heard that the complete collection of Thundercats would be received well by them."

"Thundercats?" Hammond looked lost.

"A cartoon series featuring anthropomorphic cats," Sam explained. "Humanoid cats," she added.

"Ah." Hammond nodded. "I'll see what we can do."

"They were also interested in a few Japanese series," Sam added. "Outlaw Star and All Purpose Cultural Cat Girl Nuku Nuku. And Sailor Moon."

Hammond stared at her.

Sam suppressed the urge to wince. It wasn't her fault that the Etherians had stumbled upon a Usenet group of anime fans. "However, only one of those series, the Original Video Animation of All Purpose Cultural Cat Girl Nuku Nuku" - she managed to keep as straight face repeating the title - "is available in a collected edition. The others just ended their run on Japanese TV."

"Entrapta mentioned that there were fansubs - bootlegs - available, but we explained that this might be against the law here," Daniel added.

"Ah." Hammond looked like Sam felt explaining this request. "I will see what I can do."

"Just ask your granddaughters, Sir," the Colonel added with a smirk. "They'll probably know where to get the series."

"And they'll ask for a copy for themselves, I bet." Hammond shook his head. "They and their friends apparently love the alien princesses."

"Halloween should look different this year," Daniel said.

"Well, it's good that the kids like them," the Colonel commented. "The rest of the world has some issues with our new allies. They've got something for everyone to hate. Magic! Gay marriage! Alien technology!"

"That's simplifying it a bit," Daniel spoke up. "The cultural issues go much beyond gay marriage. Their monarchism alone is a potentially huge issue for some people. And the technology transfer will cause cultural changes as well. And economic upheaval."

Sam nodded. "Entire industries might be rendered obsolete. If we can duplicate the Etherian power generation methods, we can phase out our own power plants." Clean and limitless energy. Better than fusion power.

Hammond groaned. "The lobbyists will storm Washington."

"It won't happen overnight," Sam pointed out. "It'll take years to reach a point where we can replace our power plants. And cars will continue to burn fuel for years after that, maybe decades."

"Aw. I was so looking forward to a flying pickup," the Colonel joked. Or maybe he was serious. Then he looked at Teal'c. "So, how are things with you, Teal'c?"

"I have helped the analysts with their projections of the impact of the Etherians on the Goa'uld."

"Good, good. No jealousy that you didn't get to be on TV yet? You wouldn't look as good in a dress as the Princesses, I think." The Colonel grinned.

Teal'c smiled in return. "I am content to avoid such exposure."

And he was honest about it, too, Sam knew. So different compared to many of her 'colleagues', who would already be spreading rumours about her just for having been at the United Nations.

"Well, if you feel bored, give us a call. I'm sure the Etherians would like to talk to you again as well. They have been asking about you," the Colonel said.

That would, hopefully, keep some of the agencies back home from trying anything against Teal'c in the current chaos. Not that Hammond would let anything happen to their friend, anyway.

But better safe than sorry. Everything was in flux right now. She wished she was back in the field. Or in her lab.

*****

Geneva Airport, Switzerland, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So… we're getting a multilateral meeting with the Americans, the Russians, and the Chinese?" Adora asked.

Catra briefly looked up from buttering her surprisingly tasty ‘croissant’ - it wasn’t salmon, but with honey, the thing melted in your mouth. “We do?” she asked, trying to sound as confused as possible.

“Didn’t you hear it?” Glimmer blurted out.

Adora rolled her eyes. “Glimmer, Catra does know exactly whom we are supposed to meet. She read the notes in bed.”

Catra grinned while Glimmer glared at her. Did they really think she could’ve led the entire Horde if she had actually been as lazy as she acted? “Yeah, I read the proposal. But what about the Indians? They want in on the meeting as well, according to the news we heard.”

“Aren’t they also Americans?” Adora asked.

“Not those,” Catra corrected her. “The ones from India.”

“There are two sorts of Indians?” Adora looked confused, And she wasn’t acting, Catra could tell.

“Probably,” Catra replied.

“Actually, as far as I understand - and I’ve read up on this a little - the American group was mistakenly called Indians because the Europeans thought they were in India,” Bow said. “And they’re called Native Americans now.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded. “But India is a large country. Almost as large as China and larger than the United States and Russia put together. At least if we look at the population. They should be represented, shouldn’t they?”

“But they’re not as powerful as the other three,” Hordak cut in. He looked stupid with a tiny cup held between his fingers, Catra found, but she wasn’t about to tell him that. It might hurt Entrapta, who loved those tiny things. “Their value as an ally is not as high as the others.”

“If they have many people, they can recruit a lot of troops,” Catra pointed out. India also had proportionally more young people, and that meant they would be able to easily train up infantry. Like the Horde, a low voice whispered in the back of her mind, and she clenched her teeth. “And from what SG-1 told us, even regular infantry would be good enough to fight the Goa’uld on the ground.”

“And what about their stance towards people like us?” Adora asked.

Bow grimaced, which was enough of an answer before he said: “Same-sex relationships are illegal in India.”

“Oh.” Adora frowned. “Then I don’t think we should be talking to them. If we can’t even visit the country without breaking the law, an alliance makes no sense. What about China and Russia?”

“We wouldn’t be arrested there. At least not according to the law,” Catra said.

“That’s good.” Adora nodded.

“But meeting with the three big countries is problematic,” Glimmer said. “It sets a precedent that we treat countries differently according to their power.”

“Why wouldn’t we do that?” Hordak asked. “Treating a tiny country like Switzerland the same as the most powerful country on Earth doesn’t make any sense.”

“It’s not just about power,” Glimmer told him.

“That makes even less sense.”

Catra suppressed a grin when she saw Glimmer clench her teeth.

“We want to deal with Earth - with countries that share our values. And if we single out the powerful countries, that undermines our credibility,” Glimmer explained.

Catra had to agree with the princess. “We want the people of Earth to trust us.”

“They don’t trust us,” Adora added. “Have you seen what they say about us? They called us unnatural!”

“That’s a tiny minority, as Daniel warned us,” Bow retorted.

“It was all over the news,” Adora told him.

“Daniel also warned us about that. The news has a tendency to exaggerate things to draw more attention,” he explained.

“But that’s stupid!” Adora protested. “Daniel told us that in a democracy, the majority rules, not the minority! If they’re a tiny minority, they shouldn’t be listened to by everyone! It makes people think that they aren’t a minority!”

“People like you?” Catra briefly grinned at the pout that caused. “More seriously, do we want to play their games?”

“If the three most powerful countries want to face us with a united voice, shouldn’t we accept that as their decision?” Bow asked. “Do we really want to force them to accept others in a meeting? Or to break up?”

Glimmer nodded. “If that’s their decision, then they can ask for a meeting. But we need to make it clear that we’ll be dealing with any country willing to talk to us.”

“There are almost two hundred countries, though. We’ll be here for months if we talk to every single one of them,” Adora replied.

“We can dismiss every country where our relationships would be illegal,” Catra pointed out.

“There won’t be too many countries left after that,” Glimmer said. “And how do we count countries where it’s illegal in one part and not in the other?”

“How would that work?” Catra asked. That sounded weird.

“Something about a country made up of smaller countries,” Bow explained. “A federation.”

“A country made up of other countries?” Catra was tempted to quote Hordak’s ‘that makes even less sense’.

“Forming a country.”

“Earth is a weird planet,” Adora said.

“It’s not as if we have visited many other planets,” Glimmer objected, “so we can’t make comparisons.”

“They’ll probably think that we’re the weird ones,” Bow said.

“They don’t think that. They think we’re unnatural and evil,” Adora told him.

“And sexy,” Catra added with a grin. The picture of Adora transforming into She-Ra was all over the world. And many people loved it. And her.

Adora blushed a little, then cleared her throat. “That’s not important right now. Let’s focus on politics!”

*****

Hotel Intercontinental, Geneva, Switzerland, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“I’m sorry, General, I do not know this.” Jack O’Neill said for what felt like the umpteenth time this day - and ‘umpteenth’ was a perfectly precise term, thank you very much, Daniel, he mentally added. Who had had the bright idea to have a military meeting in a luxury hotel, anyway? If the Marines ever heard of this, the Chair Force jokes would never end.

“And what would be your best estimate? You have spent weeks with the aliens, according to what we have been told. You must have built up some rapport with them,” the Russian general asked. “Do I have to remind you again that this meeting is supposed to build trust? Trust which cannot be built if you keep holding back crucial information.”

“We talked about the Goa’uld. Food. Entertainment. Physics. History. Military build-up.” Information that had been - mostly - shared with the Russians, which went against Jack’s gut feeling. “But they did not say anything concrete about magic on Earth.” Jack bared his teeth. The Russian might be a general - he certainly had the arrogance for it - but he wasn’t a soldier. Jack was sure the man was a spy.

“One of the most shocking developments, and you didn’t think to ask about the potential consequences?” The man sneered. “I doubt this, Colonel.”

“I’ve told you before that the Etherians said that they didn’t know what kind of magic Earth would have,” Jack repeated himself. At least they had told Daniel that.

“But they did know that Earth once had magic. That means that they knew about it, doesn’t it?” The Chinese general - the same rank as the Russians and the American general in the room, as usual for such meetings - smiled.

“They assume that magic was once common to all planets in the galaxy which can sustain life,” Daniel - finally! - cut in. “They base this on their own history and knowledge of the laws of magic. But as they said, and we have no reason to doubt their claims, they do not know how magic expressed itself on various planets. The current theory in Mystacore - that is their leading centre for magical research - is that magic is shaped by the environment, which includes the people on a planet.”

“You talked about the ‘laws of magic’. Laws imply a certain predictability,” the Chinese officer remarked.

"Yes. But in order to predict anything, more data is needed," Daniel said - and Jack could hear Entrapta's voice in his mind. "Data they - and we - lacked back then."

Both the Russian and the Chinese general turned their attention to Carter after hearing that. Jack saw her straighten in return. The generals had focused on Jack and Daniel so far; Jack was pretty sure that was because Carter was a woman.

"Captain Carter. You've been working closely with the aliens' expert on magic. Someone who is, again according to what we know, quite free with information. What did she say about magic on Earth?" The Chinese officer wasn't sneering - his smile didn't change - but Jack thought he caught a certain condescension in the man's tone. One he had heard from American officers when talking to or about Carter.

"Entrapta mentioned several times that she was looking forward to studying Earth's magic once it was restored," Carter replied. "It was clear that she had no expectations with regards to what kind of form this would take."

"How convenient!" the Russian exclaimed. "Of course they would claim this!"

Unspoken but clearly implied was the 'of course *you* would claim that' aimed at Jack's team.

General Naird cleared his throat. "So… I think we have covered the subject of magic extensively, right?" He smiled like a schoolboy asking the homeroom teacher if they could go play.

Jack still didn't know how the man had been chosen to represent the United States in this meeting; he wasn't part of Stargate Command's chain of command and while he had been read in on the program, he had no actual experience with Stargates or aliens. Perhaps this was an attempt to mislead the Russians and the Chinese? Jack had no doubt that both were aware that Air Force Space Command was only tangentially related to Stargate

Command, but the Russians at least might suspect that this was a ruse; they certainly were fond of pulling that stuff themselves. Or had been fond of it during the Cold War.

The two generals exchanged a glance, then the Russian nodded. "We will file a formal complaint about this."

"Of course." Naird kept smiling. "So… can we talk about space ships now? And interstellar landing operations? The topic of this meeting is the military, after all."

"We would prefer to talk a bit more about the cultural aspects of a potential alliance," the Chinese general said. "Technical details aren't as important as our ability to effectively work together in the field with aliens."

Daniel perked up, Jack saw. As he had known and as the two generals had known he would. He suppressed a sigh.

"Dr Jackson, you stressed that the Etherians consider politics a personal business. How does this translate to their armies?"

"Ah, as I said, their princesses are expected to personally lead their forces, often fighting on the front. That is not limited to those who have powers applicable to such operations - though most powers seem to have military uses - but also to princesses like Entrapta, who is one of their foremost scientists."

"They risk themselves and their researchers on the frontlines." The Russian scoffed.

"We know that," the Chinese smiled. "But how… prickly are they?"

Daniel frowned. "Do you mean how will they react to bigots and sexists working with them?"

"That seems a harsh term, but, essentially, yes."

"Well, we haven't had any such working with them, so I cannot say for sure, but…" Daniel tilted his head and pushed his glasses

up. "...I think they would take such insults personally. Any personnel assigned to work with Etherians should be chosen accordingly."

The Russian scoffed again, but the Chinese nodded. "Do you have any specific examples of issues we should be aware of?"

"Well, you shouldn't expect their monarchies to work like monarchies on Earth…" Daniel started lecturing.

Jack suppressed another sigh. He had heard this particular lecture far too often by now.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

The Secretary-General was all smiles again as he greeted them and this time, he had his wife with him. As far as Adora knew - Entrapta had researched this, but Earth's customs were confusing - that meant the meeting was meant to be less formal. Or less focused on politics. Although Entrapta had also said that this was just for appearance's sake, and a lot of politicking was done in such meetings.

Well, Adora wasn't planning to act any differently anyway - honesty and truth would win the day.

So, when Glimmer introduced them, she shook the man's hand, then his wife's and kept smiling. It was only a short meeting, anyway - they had most of the morning booked full of meetings already. Especially one with the Americans, Russians and Chinese, though technically, that was, according to Glimmer, a meeting with the Russians who would bring along the other two or something.

"So," the Secretary-General said as they had all taken sears around a low table and were sipping drinks, "I hope you kept enjoying our hospitality."

“It’s nice,” Adora said.

“Except for the protesters accusing us of wanting to corrupt Earth,” Glimmer added.

“Nutcases,” Catra muttered - loud enough to be heard around the table.

“Well, your announcement that you are considering restoring magic to Earth has caused many people to worry about the consequences,” the Secretay-General said. “As I mentioned before, it’s a controversial issue for many religions.”

“We won’t force anyone to use magic,” Adora explained, trying to keep from frowning. This whole thing didn’t make any sense.

“They are afraid of others using magic,” his wife added.

“You’ve got enough weapons to kill the whole planet several times, according to what we’ve heard, you have Goa’uld trying to conquer Earth, and you’re afraid of magic?” Catra scoffed. “I’ve fought princesses for years without magic. It’s no big deal.”

The couple seemed surprised, and Adora shook her head at her friend. Catra was trying to help, but that might not be the best way to do this. And Adora didn’t like to be reminded of the years they had fought each other.

“Indeed,” Hordak said. “My troops could hold their own against princesses most of the time with weapons that were comparable to yours. To a prepared force, magic is not a major threat by itself.”

“Well, there are exceptions, of course,” Entrapta spoke up before anyone else could say anything. “The power of a princess attuned to a runestone is far greater than that of a regular princess, and the talent and skill of sorcerers vary greatly, but absent special circumstances, magical powers won’t destroy a planet. Even destroying a city is usually out of the reach of even a princess, though I guess Perfuma and Mermista could do so thanks to their

control over plants and water. Frosta might be able to do so as well, but her power is more situational."

"A princess could destroy a city with magic? Or a planet?" The Secretary-General looked concerned now.

"In certain circumstances, but those were pretty unique to Etheria. Are unique to Etheria. As far as we know," Entrapta said. She tilted her head as her hair tendrils grabbed another drink. "Compared to what we heard of Goa'uld technology, especially bombs and biological warfare, it's not an urgent threat."

"Some might disagree with that assessment," the man said.

"Someone's always disagreeing with something," Glimmer said. "But magic hasn't hurt anyone on Earth while twice you were almost killed by the Goa'uld, so I think the real danger should be clear."

Adora nodded. "And magic can be used for so much good - you can heal people. Restore nature."

"Turn an enemy spaceship into a plant," Catra said with a grin.

"You can do that?" the Secretary-General's wife asked.

"Those were special circumstances," Adora said.

"And She-Ra is the most powerful princess in Etheria's history," Bow added. "Really, magic is… just another thing?" He shrugged with a half-smile.

"Not for many religious people," the Secretary-General's wife retorted.

"We've seen the news," Glimmer said. "But we've also seen the people who want magic returned."

Adora nodded. "They want their birthright restored." It had been nice to watch the interview with those 'Wicca', even if they had

seemed a little weird. But they liked Adora and her friends.

“But what if a country doesn’t allow magic?” the Secretary-General asked. “You can’t really limit magic to specific areas, can you?”

Adora shook her head. “No. Once I restore magic, it’ll be everywhere on the planet.”

“That’s the natural state of magic on a planet full of life,” Entrapta added.

“That’s a difficult decision, then.”

Adora frowned. “Why would it be difficult? Some people want magic restored so they can practice magic as their ancestors did. Why should anyone be allowed to forbid that? No one is forced to use magic.”

“Yes,” Catra chimed in. “It’s the same stupidity that makes idiots want to keep people like us from loving each other.” She leaned over and hugged Adora while she flashed her fangs. “Why do they think they have the right to tell others how to live? We’re not hurting anyone.”

“I see,” the Secretary-General said. “But that won’t be popular in many countries.”

“Too bad for them.” Glimmer scoffed. “We already said we won’t ally or share our technology with countries where our way of living is illegal. We’re not going to help people who hate us just for being us.”

The man smiled in response. “Well, it’ll be interesting to see how the world will react to that.”

*****

“Say…”

Samantha Carter looked up from her laptop. “Yes?”

Entrapta cocked her head at her while her hair grabbed another soda bottle from the minifridge in the small waiting room. “Why are you here and not in the meeting? I mean, you’re Earth’s foremost expert for First One’s and Goa’uld technology. At least you told us so. As did Daniel and Jack.”

“Yes,” Sam replied. This wasn’t the time for false modesty - certainly not when Entrapta might think she had been lied to. “I am the foremost expert for Stargates and advanced technology. However, there are several other scientists working in this field who might surpass me if they achieve a breakthrough in their research.” Although she couldn’t help thinking that it wasn’t very likely.

“Oh. And is your Secretary of State or your Secretary of Defense amongst them?” Entrapta flicked the soda open and took a sip from it - without using her hands.

“No,” Sam replied.

“So, why aren’t you in there?” Entrapta cocked her head to the other side.

“I’m ready to advise my superiors should it be required.”

“And that’s why you are waiting here?”

“Yes.”

“And Jack is in there. With Daniel.”

“Yes. Their expertise might be in more immediate need,” Sam explained. And they were men, which the Russians and Chinese might take more seriously. Well, good luck trying that attitude on the Etherians!

Entrapta frowned. “That sounds not very logical. Technology is the key to winning this war, isn’t it?”

“Many would think so.”

“Then you should be in there!” Entrapta firmly nodded.

“And what about you?” So far, Entrapta had been with the other Etherians in every meeting.

“Oh…” Entrapta grinned. A little sheepishly. “I got bored with all the politics.” She sighed. “No one was talking about technology in detail. I’d rather do some science, but my friends said I can’t do any experiments here. And my science buddy is talking politics as well. And strategy.” She craned her head to look at Sam’s laptop screen. “What are you doing?”

“Refining my report,” Sam told her.

“Oh?”

“Adding more detail and responding to some questions.” Sam checked that her current page didn’t contain anything that shouldn’t be revealed to Entrapta. Good.

“Ah.” Entrapta sighed again. “Say… is that urgent?”

“It’s important.”

“But is it urgent-important? Like, there’s nothing more important than that?” Entrapta leaned forward and tilted her head to smile at Sam.

Ah. Sam saved her work and closed the laptop. “What do you have in mind?”

“Wellll…” Entrapta grinned. “What do you think about using our scanner? We haven’t given Earth a full scan yet - still had to calibrate it, and we were busy with all the meetings and speeches, and there was so much data to collect from your media, but… Aren’t you curious about possible Naquadah deposits on Earth?”

Sam was actually curious. Very curious. But… She glanced at the door to the meeting room. She was supposed to be ready to advise the delegation.

"If they need your advice, they can call you with the radio or phone, right?" Entrapta asked with a hopeful expression.

"Yes." Sam nodded. And a scan of Earth was more important than waiting for her superiors. Officers were meant to show initiative. "They can. But I should inform the Colonel anyway." But she shouldn't interrupt him. So Sam suppressed a smile when she texted the Colonel.

Assisting Entrapta with a scan of Earth on request. Reachable over phone.

Her phone vibrated before she had stashed her laptop.

Lucky you. Don't blow up a country.

Sam smiled. "Let's go."

"Yes! It's time for science!" Entrapta pointed to the ceiling.

A car - armoured, Sam knew - took them to the airport, past several crowds of protesters separated by Swiss police officers and soldiers. The cardboard signs they were rising supported and denounced the war against the Goa'uld, LBGT rights and magic. The Swiss authorities had trouble keeping the protestors from fighting each other.

"I don't get it," Entrapta said as they passed a particularly unruly crowd. "Why are they so… why do they care so much about what other people do? We haven't done anything to them and we're not going to do anything to them."

Sam suppressed a wince. She wouldn't touch magic or gay marriage, and why some people were so adamantly against either being accepted on Earth. "Some think that by fighting the Goa'uld, we're endangering them. They think we could peacefully coexist

with them." It was foolish, but then, they didn't know the Goa'uld like Sam did.

"Ah." Entrapta nodded. "That makes more sense than what I thought."

"What did you think?"

"Well, Hordak speculated that they might be agents for the Goa'uld, hoping to be rewarded when the Goa'uld conquer Earth."

Sam sighed. "A fifth column?"

"A what?"

"That an Earth term for such… traitors." Sam sighed. "But, no, I doubt that they are motivated by this. They just… have a different opinion on what the Goa'uld are like."

"But they don't know the Goa'uld. They don't have any data to base their opinions on." Entrapta shook her head. "You've told them what the Goa'uld are like. Glimmer did it too. They should know better."

Sam sighed. "They don't trust us or you."

"Oh." Entrapta looked at the floor of the car. "Then we need to gain their trust."

"Easier said than done," Sam said.

"Oh, I'm sure the others have a few ideas!" Entrapta perked up.

Sam managed not to wince.

*****

"Look, we have to be pragmatic there. We're faced with an evil empire of body-snatching parasites bent on enslaving everyone in the galaxy. Fighting them has to take priority. We can sort out

cultural differences after we have ensured that we won't be destroyed."

Catra narrowed her eyes at the Secretary of Defense's words. The Russian and Chinese delegates nodded in agreement, she noted, though Daniel winced and O'Neill's face seemed frozen. Well, O'Neill had worn the same expression for pretty much the whole meeting so far. Which said a lot about his views since he generally was quite frank with them.

"Yes," the Russian diplomat said. "Our three countries have faced such a threat before, and if we had let ideological differences divide us, we wouldn't have won against an enemy as dangerous as those Goa'uld."

He was probably talking about the Nazis. Catra hadn't studied those in detail, but what she had heard about the biggest war in Earth's history, mainly from Daniel and from television, had been horrible. Horde Prime had destroyed planets, but he hadn't been so… She lacked the words to describe it.

"We know about your world war," Glimmer replied. "But we also know, from personal experience, that giving help to the wrong kind of person can lead to disaster." She glanced at Hordak.

Hordak actually stopped looking at the door through which Entrapta had vanished to 'do science with Sam' and turned to face the delegations. "Yes. Earning the trust of someone and their help, and then turning against them is a valid strategy."

Catra had to suppress a snicker when Glimmer scowled at him. Fortunately, Bow spoke up before the princess could blow up. "Yes," he said. "We don't want to hand over our technology to a country which might use it against us as soon as the Goa'uld are defeated. Or use to conquer Earth."

"And we can't fight together with people who think people like us are criminals," Adora added, wrapping an arm around Catra's

shoulder. “How can we trust anyone in battle like that?” She shook her head.

Catra smiled, enjoying the contact - and the expressions on the people’s faces - for a moment before she spoke up: “And I think we should turn the question around: If the war against the Goa’uld takes priority, why can’t you change your laws?”

“And we mean your laws,” Glimmer added with a glance at Daniel. “Not some order from your leader which can be taken back as soon as he or his successor wants to.”

The expression on the American’s face almost made Catra snicker out loud. The Secretary of State pressed his lips together before answering: “Changing our laws is a lengthy process. We’re a democracy; we can’t just skip the proper procedure.”

“Not even when we’re about to fight a war?” Adora frowned. “Isn’t your ‘parliament’ able to prioritise such things?”

“There are political considerations that hinder quick changes to laws.”

Both the Russians and the Chinese looked at the Americans, and the Russian diplomat said: “Homosexuality is legal in Russia.”

“By the letter of the law,” the American retorted. “It’s still considered a mental disorder, isn’t it?”

“That is an artefact which can be corrected immediately.”

The Chinese people nodded as well. “It will be adjusted in our country.”

“And that means people like us would enjoy the full rights like everyone else?” Adora asked.

“There is the matter of gay marriage,” the American said. “No country on Earth has legalised that yet. The hurdles for that are quite substantial.”

Catra glanced at Daniel, who was frowning and looked like he wanted to speak up but controlled himself. That told her enough. "You mean you don't want to do it."

"Russia can do it."

"As can China."

The American frowned openly. "And can you guarantee that your countries won't just reverse that at the earliest opportunity?"

"Can you guarantee the same?" The Russian shot back.

And O'Neill muttered something under his breath that sounded like a curse to Catra's twitching ears.

"Colonel?" Glimmer looked at him.

O'Neill tilted his head. "I'm here for military advice. Politics isn't my field of experience."

Daniel mouthed something to the Colonel.

"I'm just thinking that if we can't trust each other to play ball, this will be a rather short war," O'Neill said.

"But that's the question." Glimmer nodded. "Can we trust you? Can we trust you not to use our technology to conquer other countries?"

The Secretary of Defense shook his head. "Historically, all our countries have conquered foreign territory. But the United States, unlike others, hasn't done so in a hundred years."

"Russia has let the conquered countries go," the Russian claimed. "We didn't conquer any territory since the USSR was dissolved."

"China has not taken any foreign territory; we merely took back formerly Chinese territory."

"That's a matter of debate," the American said.

Catra had a pretty good idea of what that meant.

"But who can say that you won't try to colonise us? Your insistence on forcing your own customs on us is not a sign of trust," the Russian said, looking at Adora.

"We're not forcing anything on you," Adora replied. "We're just telling you the conditions under which we'll form an alliance and transfer technology. Whether or not you will accept that is up to you."

"We don't owe you anything," Glimmer added. "We want to work with you, but not at any price."

"And I am sure that there are other countries which will have an easier time with our demands," Hordak added.

That made everyone at the table opposite them frown. Well, good for them - Catra wouldn't let them play such games.

*****

"So… that happened." Jack O'Neill shook his head as he followed the Secretay of Defence and the Secretary of State out of the room.

"What happened?" Daniel asked in a low voice.

"The Etherians made it clear that they know how to play one side off against the other," Jack explained.

Daniel frowned. "But… that was clear from the beginning! I mentioned it in my report - we're dealing with sovereign rulers of their countries who have fought a lengthy war as part of an alliance. Of course they would have experience in diplomacy!"

Jack sighed. "Yes. but they're also a bunch of kids." And that made underestimating them easy. And Entrapta, who was far closer to thirty than to twenty, acted like a kid most of the time.

“I mentioned that in my report as well. They might be considered kids in the United States - actually not since all of them are over twenty years old - but they’ve been fighting for years in their war and held leadership positions for about as long. We can’t judge them according to our views.” Daniel shook his head. “I explained that!”

“Yes, you did.” The Secretary of State obviously had overheard them. “But you also mentioned that they were not familiar with our customs and policies.”

“Yes, I did.” Daniel looked confused.

Jack snorted again. “Which meant some people thought they could manipulate them.”

“Oh.”

“I would describe it as a slight miscalculation,” the Secretary of Defense cut in, slightly pouting. “Although I think the Russians and the Chinese were more surprised.”

“But they correctly calculated that the Etherians do not care as much about democracy as we do,” Daniel interjected. “That part didn’t even come up.”

Jack’s nominal superior frowned even more. “This was supposed to be a meeting about military cooperation.”

“And now we know that without gay marriage, we won’t get cooperation,” Daniel said.

“That was their opening offer,” the Secretary of State objected. “We’ve barely started negotiations.”

“Ah…” Daniel smiled in that apologising way of his that he usually used when trying to pass on bad news. “I don’t think they’ll budge on this point.”

“It’s more like a red line,” Jack agreed.

"Yes." Daniel nodded twice. "They do take politics personally, after all, and they don't see such discrimination as negotiable."

"But they have to be aware that the Russians and the Chinese will promise anything to get advanced technology, and then turn around and do whatever they want to their gay population!" The Secretary of State shook his head. "You just said that they weren't that naive!"

"They aren't naive. But they…" Daniel sighed and pushed his glasses up again. "They lack a democratic tradition. They are used to dealing with monarchs. Absolute rulers. They'll focus on them."

"Ah. So… they'll want to meet the Russian President and the Supreme Leader of the Chinese before formalising anything. Good." The Secretary of Defense stared at Jack and Daniel. "You'll need to tell them why they can't trust the Russian and the Chinese."

"But I thought we're negotiating with them to present a unified front," Daniel replied.

"We are. But that won't happen if the Russians or the Chinese can get an alliance on their own."

"Do you want us to… influence the Etherians?" Daniel sounded as if someone had told him to seduce a princess for the benefit of the country.

"Just tell them the truth about Russia and China. The Holodomor. The Great Leap Forward."

"Ah. But… that's in the past. The Etherians are big on giving second chances and people changing," Daniel retorted. "They spent years fighting a war against Hordak and Catra. Entrapta changed sides twice during the war. And yet, they're now friends." He shook his head. "Telling them about past atrocities won't do much, in my opinion."

The Secretary of Defense scoffed through clenched teeth. "Just do what you have to to stop them from blindly trusting the Russians and the Chinese. We can't let them get advanced technology first."

Unfortunately, the man was right about that - if the Chinese and the Russians got their hands on advanced technology and the United States didn't, then that would have dire consequences for the world. Even if the Etherians stepped in and stopped any attempts to force concessions from the rest of the world, that would still destroy any semblance of a balance of power, "We'll see what we can do," Jack said. "But we won't lie to them."

"Yes. Honesty is the key to reaching an agreement with them," Daniel added. "We need to trust each other, and we can't if we start with lies."

"Don't lie. But be as honest about Russia and China as you were about the United States." The Secretary nodded at them, then turned and walked away.

Daniel looked at Jack.

"Well, he got you there," Jack told him with a grin he didn't quite feel.

"Jack!"

"Sorry. But you did explain our faults at lengths, didn't you?"

"I wanted to avoid any misunderstandings!"

"Well, you tried." Jack shook his head. "Anyway, we've got our…" His phone vibrated, and he held up his hand as he pulled it out. "It's Carter."

We did a scan of Earth. Please meet us at the ship. Entrapta is calling the others.

“She wants us to come to the ship,” Jack said. That wouldn’t reassure their allies that the United States wasn’t hiding something. But Carter was aware of that. “Well, if the Etherians invite us, it would be rude to decline the invitation.”

But he had a bad feeling about this.

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The Naquadah Crisis Part 1

Geneva Airport, Switzerland, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"What did you find?" Adora asked as soon as she entered the converted hold where Sam and Entrapta were usually working. Had been working, she corrected herself - now that they were back on Earth, Sam would probably not be working here any more.

"Let's wait for the others," Sam said.

The others? Ah, yes. Jack and Daniel were coming too. "Sorry," Adora said. They probably were as tired of politics as she was.

"As long as they hurry," Catra added, stretching her arms over her head.

"Catra!" Glimmer snapped.

"What?" Catra frowned. "Wait, you're right. The longer they take, the longer we have before we have to talk to those idiots from Russia, China nad the USA again."

"They aren't idiots," Adora corrected her.

"Could've fooled me. They were practically backstabbing each other at the table," Catra retorted.

"Well…" Adora trailed off. They had acted like that, hadn't they?

"That's normal. Remember the first Alliance meetings we attended?" Glimmer smiled at Bow, who nodded with a wry smile.

Well, it wasn't normal for Adora. She shook her head. "We really need to…"

But before she could finish, a beep announced that Jack and Daniel had arrived. Well, it could be anyone, actually, but the codes checked out. And she could see them on the cameras.

A minute later - because they wouldn't open the airlock remotely without personally checking - they were back in the hold.

"So, Captain, what did you find?" Jack asked right away. Was he mad about the meeting? He had seemed annoyed, but had that been aimed at Adora and her friends - or at the others?

Sam looked at Entrapta, who had been twitching a little - and her hair had been twitching a lot - since Adora had arrived. "I think Entrapta could fill you in best, Sir."

"Yes!" Entapta blurted out with a wide - very wide - smile. "We ran the magic scanner, calibrated for Naquadah, over all of Earth! We had to tweak the detector algorithm a little to compensate for the presence of the escorts and the planetary mantle in the way - it would've been easier if we could've done this from orbit, even geostationary orbit, but Sam said taking off might cause some trouble, and asking for permission felt rather weird if we could easily tweak the scanner instead of bothering the Swiss, so, anyway: We ran the scanner, and we found Naquadah!"

"You found a Naqadah deposit?" Jack asked.

"Ah… no." Entrapta shook her head, her hair flailing. "It looks too dense - too concentrated for that. And there's not enough for a deposit unless it was almost completely mined out."

"We think we found artefacts of advanced technology on Earth, Colonel," Sam said.

"Yes! And we marked their positions!" Entrapta's hair tendrils pushed a few buttons, and a hologram appeared in the middle of the room, showing earth. Blinking lights were visible in a few spots.

“That’s… Washington, near Seattle,” Daniel said. “And the coast before New Jersey.”

“And Siberia,” Jack added. “And Honduras.”

“And Egypt!” Daniel tilted his head. “Well, that was to be expected, actually, since the Stargate was originally there. There must be many lost devices or trash containing Naquadah.”

“Well, the biggest and most diverse amount of Naquadah is in… Washington, you said?” Entrapta cocked her head and had her hair point at the location. “The other locations don’t have a lot, although the one in Egypt is a little fuzzy.”

“Fuzzy?” Jack raised his eyebrows.

“The Scanner detected some interference. It might be the result of micro-contamination with Naquadah,” Sam told him. “That would hinder detection.”

“Like chaff?”

“Not exactly,” Sam said.

“But close enough?” Jack grinned.

Sam looked a little pained. “Yes, Sir.”

“So… we have a cache of Naquadah devices on US soil,” Jack said. “And another load in US territorial waters.”

“Actually, no, Sir - it’s outside US territorial waters,” Sam said. “I checked.”

“Great. More international trouble.” Jack sighed.

“How sad.” Catra flashed her fangs when Jack glared at her, and Adora sighed. Her love sometimes - OK, a lot of times - was a little too… antagonistic.

Adora cleared her throat. “Given the potential threat those things represent, I think they need to be recovered quickly.”

“Yesssss.” Jack nodded, drawing out the word. “It’s the manner of how they should be recovered that’s going to pose some problems.”

“You mean the United States can’t just grab most of it,” Glimmer said.

“That’s about it, yes.” Jack grinned at Adora’s friend.

“We need to tell the Egyptians. They need to know that they might have dangerous relics in their country,” Daniel said.

“And what if they become a danger once they recover them?” Jack looked at his friend.

“A greater danger than the United States?” Catra asked.

“The United States are more trustworthy than Egypt,” Jack argued. “We’ve been the most powerful country for decades, and even with advanced technology, we didn’t go after other countries. Not without good reasons,” he added when Daniel opened his mouth.

Adora frowned. That sounded… loaded.

“Sure you would say that,” Catra grinned again.

“Are you accusing me of lying?” Jack retorted.

“Is it lying if you leave out information that might make your country look bad?” Catra’s grin turned very toothy.

“We didn’t,” Daniel cut in. “Not deliberately, at least. We - that is, I - actually covered the United States more than the rest of the world. But maybe we should explain a few things about the other countries.”

Adora nodded. They wouldn't want to make a mistake if they could avoid it. And she trusted Daniel not to lie to them. "Yes, please. We need to deal with those… whatever they are, and we need information for that."

"Data!" Entrapta chimed in.

Catra sighed, but Glimmer and Bow nodded, and Daniel pushed his glasses up.

"Alright. Let's start with Russia! The country's an old one, but it went through a lot of changes this century. First…"

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"...and the Chinese state has been cracking down on the movement ever since."

Samantha Carter nodded as Daniel trailed off. It had been quite a decent summary of the history of Russia and China. Not as succinct as may have been possible, but not as meandering as she had feared either.

But it had clearly disturbed the Etherians. Adora was shaking her head. "To think people could do such things!"

"Horde Prime did worse," Glimmer pointed out with a frown.

"He was… well, we already knew after we learned about the Goa'uld that he wasn't as unique as we thought," Bow told her.

"And he was more efficient," Hordak commented.

"'Efficient'?" The Colonel narrowed his eyes, Sam noticed - and he sounded slightly tense.

"Yes." Hordak nodded. "He dealt much more swiftly with, ah, dissenters. Resistance. He wouldn't have let things be dragged out like this."

“Wow. What a great guy.” The Colonel scoffed.

The alien frowned for a moment, looking puzzled as far as Sam could tell, before nodding in agreement. “He was great, yes. Terrible and cruel, but no one can deny that he was great.”

“Too bad we can’t get an autograph from him any more,” the Colonel added, baring his teeth.

“Jack!” Daniel gasped.

“Colonel!” Sam said in a lower voice as the Etherians stared at either Hordak or the Colonel or both.

“Horde Prime was a monster,” Glimmer hissed.

“A great monster,” Entrapta agreed, patting Hordak’s arm.

“And he’s dead,” Catra said, rolling her eyes. Her tail was twitching, though. “So, can we focus on the Naquadah stuff we need to recover? Instead of on ancient history?”

“Well… it’s not exactly ancient history,” Daniel said. “Those events happened a few years ago or are happening now.”

“And you told us that, so we’ll stop negotiating with the Russians and the Chinese,” Catra said with a sneer.

Daniel blushed a little. “That’s what some people hope will happen. But I told you this so you can make an informed decision. Or, at least, so you will not blindly trust any claims made to you.”

“They will claim anything so they can get your technology,” the Colonel added.

“They’re not the only ones,” Glimmer replied.

“No. But we’ve been pretty honest with you.” The Colonel smiled, then sighed. “I know my country isn’t perfect - no country is - but

we don’t claim that we can simply change a law, and everything is fine.”

Catra snorted. “No. You claim you can’t even change a law.”

“Ah, there are good reasons to make changing a law - or the constitution - not too easy,” Daniel cut in. He adjusted his glasses. “You don’t want to change either on a whim. And you generally want to have broad support for such a change, not a minimal majority. In a democracy, I mean. But even in a kingdom, you wouldn’t want to live where the rules and laws change too easily. People need stability in their lives.”

“Yes. But people don’t need discrimination,” Glimmer retorted. “How can we trust your country when the majority of your people won’t end discrimination?”

Daniel winced. “It’s a bit more complicated than that. It’s not the majority of the people, but the majority of the representatives and the senators - the qualified majority, for amendments to the constitution.”

“But they are supposed to represent the people.” Glimmer frowned.

“Yes, but that doesn’t mean that they are supposed to just do whatever the population wants.”

“I thought that was the point of democracy,” Adora said. She looked honestly confused.

“The founders of the United States didn’t want what they deemed ‘mob rule’, so they created a system where power was divided between several institutions. And the people get to choose who represents them in those institutions. But they don’t get to directly make decisions,” Daniel explained.

“So… basically, you pick your council of princesses and hope for the best,” Catra said. “And then you wonder why nothing good comes of such a council.”

“Catra!”

“What?” Catra turned to pout at Adora. “I know how the Alliance leadership worked. Or didn’t work. Glimmer complained about it often enough when she had some drinks.”

Hordak nodded. “Glimmer’s talent for leading the alliance was most impressive given the circumstances.”

Glimmer looked, in Sam’s opinion, as if she didn’t know whether she should be angry or flattered upon hearing that.

She picked angry and spat: “Everyone did their best.” Then she turned to glare at the Colonel and Daniel. “And I don’t understand why you think it’s difficult to stop discriminating people like us. We don’t hurt you at all. It should be a no-brainer to adjust your laws and form an alliance. You have nothing to lose and everything to gain!”

“Well, it’s complicated,” Daniel said. “Many people honestly believe that relationships like yours are wrong. And they don’t want to let others do what they consider a mistake or a sin.”

“Those people are idiots,” Catra spat with a hiss. “And you’re idiots if you listen to them.”

“Many people think all politicians are idiots,” the Colonel said with a grin.

“You’re not exactly convincing us of the values of democracy,” Glimmer commented.

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Catra shook her head. This discussion again! Couldn’t they just admit that it wasn’t working as well as they claimed?

“The advantage of democracy is the ability to change governments peacefully and in an organised fashion which

ensures continuity and stability along with the capability to adapt to changing circumstances," Daniel said.

"I'm not seeing much of that vaunted ability to adapt right now." Catra snorted. "And leadership doesn't mean simply going along with what your troops want. It means making them do what they need to do no matter what they want." Troops rarely had the big picture. Of course, she had sometimes missed the big picture herself - in quite spectacular fashion…

"But we're not talking about military leadership," Daniel protested.

"We're talking about an alliance for the war against the Goa'uld," Catra told him. "That's a military question."

"But gay marriage is not a military question," O'Neill retorted.

"Your policy of dismissing gay soldiers is a military matter, though," Adora pointed out.

"And that can be changed by the president." O'Neill held up his hands. "We want to do the right thing, but it's not as easy. But once we do something, it sticks."

"And if you do the wrong thing?" Adora asked.

"Well, Churchill once said that the USA will try every wrong solution before they use the right one," Daniel commented, then winced when O'Neill glared at him. "But unlike other countries, change supported by the population is generally far more effective. Just changing a law means nothing if the population ignores the changes and opposes its enforcement."

"But if the reason you can't change the law is that the population doesn't support it, then that's even worse." Glimmer shook her head. "Like with slavery and those civil rights."

"That was mostly in the south," O'Neill said. "Things were different in the other parts of the country."

“And that was a result of the federal nature of the country,” Daniel said. “As with many things, federalism had good and bad consequences. If a ruler has absolute power, that can lead to many good things - if the ruler is good and wise. But if they aren’t, if they are foolish or evil, then the same system can lead to horrible results.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Yeah, yeah. But that still doesn’t change that your country wouldn’t accept our relationship.”

Daniel produced a weak smile. “Well, the relationship isn’t illegal. Just gay marriage isn’t recognised.”

“Even though it’s recognised on Etheria?” Glimmer shook her head. “If you won’t recognise our institutions, an alliance won’t work.”

“Whether the United States legalises gay marriage or not doesn’t really change your relationship,” O’Neill cut in. “What about polygamy? Multiple marriages,” he added. “What if there’s one man married to multiple women?”

Catra frowned. “What about it?” Lonnie, Kyle and Rogelio hadn’t married yet, but it was on the table as far as Catra knew.

O’Neill stared at her, then mumbled: “Figures…”

Daniel cleared his head. “In any case, I think the most important aspect is whether or not a change is both enforced and lasting. And history is full of examples where a change imposed on a population took years or decades to become accepted.”

Catra snorted. “If you can’t enforce your orders, you’re not a leader.”

Glimmer glanced at her, then looked at SG-1. “But that’s the thing, right? Your population doesn’t want this change.”

“Well, that’s not certain,” Daniel said. “So far, the question of gay marriage has never been coupled with something like an alliance

or technological advances. Although, while this should influence acceptance positively even amongst religious people - to paraphrase Berthold Brecht, people prioritise wealth over morals - some might resent that, feeling forced."

"Oh, those poor people, being forced to stop discriminating people like us!" Glimmer scoffed. "How do you expect an alliance to work if you can't even treat us like everyone else?"

"Well, it worked with Saudi Arabia and Kuwait in the Gulf War," O'Neill said. "Tolerance goes up on both sides if you need each other."

"Within limits," Carter added. "Female soldiers were tolerated, but not accepted." She seemed about to add something but stopped herself.

"Well, then I guess we'll see how badly your country wants this alliance." Glimmer shook her head.

Catra snorted. "So, let's go back to the Naquadah items."

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded several times. "We need to examine them - they could be anything!"

"That's a little difficult," Daniel said. "Not all of them are in areas we can reach."

"Well, we could, but the diplomats would be angry with us," O'Neill added.

Catra shook her head. She didn't really miss the Horde, just… sometimes, she really missed being able to give orders or do something without having to ask everyone else if it was OK.

"And there's the question of precedent even for the items in Seattle," Daniel said. "If we just grab those, other countries will consider artefacts on their soil theirs to do with as they please. And there are a lot of artefacts in Egypt, it seems, one in Russia, one in Honduras…"

"Great," O'Neill muttered. "We have to pass this up the chain before we can do anything."

Well, at least someone else has the same problem, Catra thought.

"Can't we secure the artefacts and then sort out who gets them?" Adora asked. "Some of them might be dangerous. What if there's a Goa'uld on Earth?"

That question had everyone wincing.

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"Yes, Sir. There's a possibility that we're facing a Goa'uld on Earth," Jack O'Neill said, nodding at the large screen on the bridge of Darla, where General Hammond and Teal'c were looking at him. "The concentrations of Naquadah Captain Carter and Princess Entrapta have detected could easily include a snake." And his gut told him that this was probably the case. No matter what Carter said about probabilities.

"They could just be collections of artefacts," Teal'c pointed out. "Remains from before Ra left."

"Yes. But then, who collected them? Who brought so much Naquadah to Seattle? It wasn't Starbucks trying to create an Egyptian Latte." On the other hand, if it turned out that Starbucks was a vehicle for an alien infiltration, that would explain why that franchise had spread so far despite their horrible prices…

Hammond slowly nodded with a sigh. "And even if there's no Goa'uld present, we can't risk such a collection of advanced technology falling into the wrong hands."

"Unless it already has," Jack reminded his commanding officer. "We need to recover those artefacts. And it has to be done by someone with the experience to handle whatever might be hiding there." SG-1, in other words. And probably the Etherians.

“That will be difficult in the current situation, Colonel.” Hammond looked grim. “Washington was quite clear that we need to regain the trust of our allies at almost any cost. Unilaterally recovering alien technology from foreign countries would destroy what headway we made in that area.” He shook his head. “Even recovering the technology on US soil will be a delicate affair.”

“But we can’t ignore the danger a Goa’uld hiding on earth would present!” Daniel protested. “Or their technology.”

“Yes.” Hammond smiled wryly. “I’ll take it up with my superiors. You will probably be called to brief the President soon, Colonel.”

“Yes, Sir.” Jack nodded. That was likely. He wasn’t looking forward to it, though. He wanted to go out and recover the Goa’uld technology. Do something productive, for once - discussing politics with the Etherians wasn’t helping anyone.

“Hammond out.”

The image faded to black. “Well, let’s tell our friends that we’ve made the call,” Jack said. Not that he thought he had to tell them - this was their ship, after all. Hell, the way Entrapta talked to and about the ship, the ship might have told the Etherians already.

But appearances had to be upheld. Jack walked to the door and found Catra and Adora waiting outside. “Done already?” the catwoman asked.

Jack shrugged. “It’s out of my hands now. Up to diplomats.”

She scoffed. “And now we wait until they figure out how to do anything without ruffling any feathers?”

“Pretty much, yes.” Jack grinned widely. “And more politics!”

“That’s Glimmer’s job.” Catra scoffed again.

“Oh, you’ve been quite active in the meetings yourself, haven’t you?” Jack cocked his head.

She scowled at him, which made him grin more widely.

Adora cleared her throat. “But Catra is correct - we can’t just let this go on. The risk is too great.”

“Yes,” Daniel agreed. “Your arrival has changed the entire world and might prompt whoever controls those artefacts into action.”

Adora nodded. “And that means that we need to act.” She raised her chin. “And if we need an international agreement on this, then let’s get one right away!”

“From the United Nations?” Jack snorted. “We’ll be here for a year before they agree on who gets to speak first. And that won’t do anything, anyway.” Everyone knew UN resolutions were generally ignored. “All it would do is to alert everyone else about this - and start a race for the Naquadah.”

But Adora looked mulish. “We’ll have to see about that. This calls for action. Even your diplomats need to see that.”

“Feel free to try,” Jack said, shrugging. “I bet we’ll get called in shortly after things go out of control. If we’re lucky.”

“Then let’s talk to the Security Council. If they can’t do anything, then we can always act ourselves,” Adora said. “After all, no matter what the UN decides, we’re fighting the Goa’uld, and so we won’t just ignore a potential base of them.”

Ah. Jack almost smiled. Almost - the threat of the Etherians going ahead and tracking down Goa’uld on Earth without the consent of the countries affected would hopefully spur the UN Security Council into action. But it would also strengthen the faction that wanted the aliens gone or feared them taking over Earth. Still, they really couldn’t ignore the potential danger.

Another fine mess, and it was all the fault of the damn snakes.

“Well, let’s go then. The sooner we sic Glimmer on the United Nations, the sooner we can move,” he said. “I bet she’ll scare

them into doing something."

"Jack! You can't talk about a reigning Queen that way!"

He chuckled at Daniel's expression. Catra outright laughed, and Adora frowned in that way of hers that told Jack that she wanted to laugh as well but thought it was wrong.

As it turned out, Glimmer was all too ready to call for an emergency session. "Oh, yes! That should speed up negotiations! Once they see our technology in action, they will know what they are missing. And those who claim that the Goa'uld aren't a threat will shut up!"

"But they'll expect to share the Goa'uld technology we recover," Bow pointed out.

Glimmer snorted. "We can hand it over to the United Nations - they'll have to agree on what to do with it before they can even start trying to use the technology."

And such an agreement, Jack knew, could take a long while.

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and that's the last area with a substantial concentration of Naqadah!"

Adora watched the Security Council as Entrapta pointed at the holoprojection floating in the middle of the room. They didn't give much away, or not much that she could tell, but she thought they were concerned. Of course, being concerned about potential enemies on your planet was just common sense, and some of the people on Earth didn't have common sense at all, so she might be seeing things that weren't there…

Glimmer cleared her throat. “As you’ve seen, there are multiple locations on Earth that could hide a Goa’uld - or more of them. They can take over humans as easily as animals, as we found out on the way to Earth when we found a planet where Goa’uld had taken over large predators. Even leaving out the danger such advanced technology represents should it fall into the wrong hands, we need to make sure that there aren’t any Goa’uld on Earth.”

A delegate - from one of the small countries which didn’t have veto power, Adora knew - tapped their microphone. “But you don’t have actual proof that one of those aliens is present on our planet, do you?”

Hadn’t they explained that already? Adora frowned. And she saw that Glimmer clenched her teeth for a moment.

But her friend controlled her temper. “No, we don’t have proof. But the only way to get proof is to investigate those locations.”

“Surely the affected countries can investigate their own soil,” the Russian delegate commented.

“With the possible exception of the United States,” Glimmer replied, “I don’t believe any country on Earth has the experience and resources to handle the worst-case scenario: A Goa’uld with access to advanced technology who has been infiltrating Earth for hundreds of years.” She shook her head. “You don’t have the technology to detect Goa’uld in the field. They could easily go into hiding - or take over your own people. We can deal with them with the least risk.”

“That would be an intrusion on the territory of sovereign countries,” a third delegate commented. Again, a minor country. “If it’s done without the consent of the country in question.”

“And it could be seen as the attempt to deprive a country of its own resources,” the first delegate added. “Surely those Naquadah artefacts belong to the country on which soil they are found -

that's a basic principle. Unless they were taken from their country of origin, of course - we all know how many works of art and historical artefacts were taken from our countries and moved into the museums of colonial powers."

Adora bit her lip. This was a threat to the entire planet! This wasn't the time to squabble over resources!

The Chinese delegate spoke up: "We're faced with a threat against our entire planet. Single countries cannot deal with such a threat. This is the responsibility of all of us and should be treated accordingly. Therefore, we propose to put all alien artefacts under international control."

Adora wondered, privately, what the Chinese would have said if there were Naquadah artefacts in China.

The Russian delegate leaned towards his own microphone. "Would that include the advanced technology already recovered by certain countries?"

"Yes, of course. The time for single countries to face the Goa'uld and endanger our entire planet has gone. We need a united response to this thread." The Chinese delegate slowly nodded.

"The United States have the most experience with the technology recovered so far," the American delegate objected. "It makes no sense and could cripple the war effort to remove the technology already being used to fight the Goa'uld. Especially in light of our success so far."

"You almost got Earth invaded twice," the Russian shot back.

"Keeping the technology recovered so far would seem to reward the United States for their questionable actions in the past," another delegate cut in.

"Trying to take over a sovereign country's research and development programs would set a precedent that I doubt most countries here would want," the American countered.

“Maybe it is time to unite such programs,” the French delegate suggested. “We cannot afford to waste our resources, and uncoordinated research by various countries would surely be less efficient than a coordinated program under international control and guidance?”

“I think the outcome of the Cold War has decisively proven that competition drives progress far more efficiently than planned directives from the state,” the American delegate pointed out.

“Your Stargate program was entirely driven and controlled by the government,” the Russian retorted. “And international control over the existing alien technology - including artefacts recovered prior to today - seems a suitable response to this threat.”

Glimmer cleared her throat. “Why are you focusing on the technology already recovered instead of the imminent threat to the planet? We first need to ensure that Earth is safe. And that means investigating and securing those Naquadah artefacts we discovered and hunting down any infiltrating Goa’uld.”

“That’s a tricky matter involving international law and can’t be easily solved,” someone pointed out.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes. “We’re in a war, and those are potential enemy bases. We cannot afford to leave them be until you have sorted out who gets to use all the technology you might find or have found. Time is of the essence.”

The delegates looked at each other. “To clarify,” another of the smaller countries’ delegates asked, “are you talking about a response by the Princess Alliance or a response by a multi-national force?”

“I am telling you that the Princess Alliance cannot afford to let potential enemy bases be. The risk is too great,” Glimmer said. “We’re at war with the Goa’uld. We want to work with you - but not if that means we can’t deal with a potential threat.”

"We have enough ships in the fleet to stop an invasion from space," Adora added. "But that won't help if the invasion already started on Earth." Well, they could bombard sites from orbit, but if the Goa'uld hid amongst humans…

This time, she could plainly see that the delegates were concerned.

She hoped that that was a good thing.

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Geneva Airport, Switzerland, August 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter suppressed a yawn as she entered Darla's hold. It was early, and she hadn't had too much sleep. And she was still affected by the jetlag to some degree. But she had no time to sleep in - not with the current crisis brewing. She had had to brief the President and his cabinet until midnight, and it was barely six in the morning.

She took a sip from her coffee - the situation wasn't nearly dire enough to brave Entrapta's 'concentrated tiny tea' and walked over to the scanner. "Good morning."

"Sam!" Entrapta whipped her head around to smile at her. "You're here early!" She blinked. "I think?"

"I'm just a few minutes early," Sam corrected her. "Any changes during the night?"

"Well… the position of some of the artefacts in your country changed a little. Not by very much, but either they were moving around a bit - say, a few dozen metres, tops - or the scanner needs some adjusting," Entrapta said, cocking her head. Her goggles hid her eyes, but Sam knew the princess well enough to know they would be showing the woman's fatigue.

But this was alarming. That looked like someone was carrying the Naqadah concentrations around. "Did you check the calibration?" Sam asked.

"All night," Entrapta replied. "I think I improved the efficiency, but the results didn't change. Well, they kept changing, but that didn't change. You know what I mean."

"Yes." As Sam knew that Entrapta needed to rest. What was Hordak thinking, letting her work like this? And, speaking of… "Where's Hordak?"

"Oh, he has been working on ways to recover the Naquadah under the sea. He said we might need a specialised vessel or a bot," Entrapta replied. "I wanted to help, but then the scanner started showing movement, so I took over here and left him to his work." Her hair pointed to the door leading into the next part of the hold.

Sam glanced at it. "The United States Navy has submarines and trained divers," she pointed out. The artefacts weren't that deep - there was no need for a deep-submergence vehicle.

"But we need to go down there as well," Entrapta retorted. "How else can we do something if things go wrong?"

That was… well, it was the kind of argument Sam should've expected. The Etherians were very 'hands-on'. Or, a less kind interpretation, they didn't trust others to do such a mission.

Then again, Sam wouldn't trust the Navy either - they had no experience with Goa'uld or their technology. "I think the Naquadah in Seattle takes priority," she said. She finished her coffee just as her phone vibrated.

"Samantha Carter."

"Carter?" It was the Colonel. *"We've got a situation."*

Oh. "In Seattle?"

"How would you… The scanner showing movement?"

"Yes, Sir. Entrapta just informed me that the Naquadah concentrations are moving around - about a few dozen yards, tops."

He scoffed. *"Yeah, that would track. Anyway, the location was placed under surveillance - it's some resort or communal ranch or whatever. A religious community, according to the records."*

"A cult?"

"Don't let Daniel hear that," he joked. *"Anyway, we were still planning how best to approach that without tipping off a Goa'uld and without ruining our diplomatic reputation further when someone raided the resort."*

Sam closed her eyes. "The NID?"

"They claim that they have no information about any such operation."

The old 'rogue NID cell' excuse then. "What happened?"

"They got in and didn't get out. Shots were heard by the other agents in place, but no one called the police."

That was even more worrying. "We need to intervene, Sir!" SG-1 need to intervene. Before things deteriorated even further. If the Goa'uld managed to take control of NID operatives…

"Yes, we do. But we can't do it alone - not with the Security Council about to decide that this is an international affair under their control or something. And I bet that our alien friends will jump at this."

"I concur, Sir." And given the possible consequences of a Goa'uld base on American soil, having the Etherians with them was a good thing.

"So, the excuse will be that we have reports of fighting, and so we're sending in troops with the Etherians. That should shut up the complaints from other countries. And probably get the diplomats to finish their wheedling and dealing before the heat death of the Universe."

She laughed at the joke. "I'll inform them, Sir."

"Good. We're on our way to the ship. We'll be picking up Teal'c on the way."

"Yes, Sir."

He hung up, and Sam turned to Entrapta, who was staring at her with - presumably - wide eyes. "There's been an incident in Seattle," Sam told her.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded several times. "I'll call the others. Wait! Darla! Wake up the others and get ready for liftoff! Hordak! Science-Buddy! We have a mission!"

The door from the other part of the hold opened, and Hordak stepped through. "Did they find a Goa'uld?"

"Possibly?" Entrapta pursed her lips. "Someone's in control of all that Naquadah, and they fought off an attack already. So… either a Goa'uld or someone else. But I bet it'll be interesting! And we can now go there without waiting for the Security Council!"

"Good. Any hope that we can expect similar developments in the other areas?"

"I don't know - the stuff there didn't move."

"A pity," Hordak commented.

Sam shook her head.

*****

Above Seattle, United States of America, Earth, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Any new developments?" Catra asked as Darla closed in on the target area. It was still night here, unlike when they had taken off in Switzerland.

"The Naqadah concentrations keep moving around," Carter reported. "But none of them have strayed outside the resort."

"They were attacked…" Catra checked the clock. "...almost two hours ago. And they didn't move? Haven't they realised that they have been exposed?" This was suspicious.

"They might think this was an attempted robbery, not a government action," O'Neill said. "The NID is quite careful when staging their deniable operations. So they probably want to interrogate any prisoners for more information. In their place, I would want to know who attacked me and why before I made any plans."

"But whether there's a Goa'uld or just someone using their technology, they have to know about our arrival," Adora cut in. "Why wouldn't they expect us to come after them?"

Catra nodded. In their place, she would have been running already.

"If they don't know how they were found, they might not want to flee and give up whatever resources they have in the resort," O'Neill replied.

That was a good point. Still, the enemy should have run - now that Darla had arrived, the enemy couldn't escape any more. Catra scoffed. "Well, whatever they planned, time's just run out for them."

"Well, let's just make sure that none of them can run out on us," O'Neill said. "We've got the perimeter under surveillance, but… if

they have alien technology, they might have other options to escape."

"Scans show an extensive underground network of chambers and tunnels," Carter reported.

"Yesss!" Entrapta nodded. A lot.

Catra winced. They should've made sure that Entrapta rested instead of working through the night. With all the 'concentrated tea' she had drunk, she hadn't even been able to sleep during the flight to Denver and then here.

"So… escape tunnels?"

"It looks like it, Sir," Carter replied. "We've marked the exits on the map."

"Major Warren? We need to deploy SG-3 to cover those exits," O'Neill said, turning to the new officer on the bridge.

Catra bit her tongue to refrain from making a comment. SG-3, currently filling the hold, was under O'Neill's command. And they were supposed to work together in a 'joint operation' with them.

As long as they didn't get into their way… Catra would still feel better once the soldiers were off Darla.

"I'll brief the men, Colonel."

"There's one irregularity, Sir." Carter frowned.

"Yes?"

"There's a large tunnel not connected to the main building or any building," Carter explained. "It has an exit outside the compound, though."

"An unfinished escape tunnel?" O'Neill frowned.

“That’s a possibility, Sir. But why would they have dug so far from the outside instead of starting inside - or from both sides?” Carter asked.

“Good question,” O’Neill said, nodding. “I’d say they are stupid, but… stupid people don’t overwhelm an NID assault.”

“And we shouldn’t underestimate our enemies,” Adora added.

“Let’s just block the exit and leave it be for now,” O’Neill said.

Catra pressed her lips together. Something didn’t add up there. But O’Neill was right - sealing the exit should work.

“Yes, Sir,” Warren said.

“Good. So… how are we going to do this?” O’Neill asked.

Catra stepped closer to the hologram depicting the resort - including the escape tunnels. From what they had observed, the people inside the resort were not heavily armed. Just small arms and some crew-served light support weapons.

“We can hover above the building and drop down through the roof,” Adora said. “Right into their midst.”

Subtle as a brick, Catra thought with a fond smile. But sometimes, brute force was the best solution.

“If they have Goa’uld weapons, that might be very dangerous,” O’Neill said.

“And we can’t just blow up the resort - we don’t know how many innocent people are in there,” Daniel added.

“We’re not going to blow up the building!” Adora shook her head.

Catra bit her tongue again. And Hordak looked confused but, for once, didn’t comment.

“Well, we could sneak in,” Bow suggested. “Use the tunnels that we know.”

“They are likely trapped if this is the work of a Goa’uld,” Teal’c said.

“We can deal with traps!” Entrapta announced.

“We could drop Adora outside and have her draw attention, and we sneak in and hit them from behind,” Glimmer proposed.

“I can handle them, yes,” Adora said.

Catra sighed through clenched teeth. She loved the idiot, but sometimes… But it was a better plan than dropping into the middle of the compound. “Well, we should look into…” She trailed off.

All the Naquadah markers were suddenly moving - spreading out.

And people ran out of the buildings, towards the garage - and the gates.

“We need to move in now!” O’Neill barked.

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The Naquadah Crisis Part 2

Above Seattle, United States of America, Earth, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill clenched his teeth. They had to move quickly before whoever or whatever was in this compound scattered - tracking down dozens of potential Goa'uld hosts would be a nightmare even with the scanner. If they got into Seattle or another city…

"Move in where?" Adora asked, returning to the captain's chair.

Jack turned to the holographic projection. "Zoom out."

"Show us the road network," Catra added.

The projection changed, becoming a 3D view of the entire area around the compound. "We need to block the main routes - we can track down any stragglers on foot later." He looked at the agents in place and made a snap decision. "Major Warren, deploy SG-3 here, here and here." He tapped the locations. "Spread out to shield Seattle. Go!"

"Yes, Sir." Warren finished marking the spots and rushed out of the bridge to brief his men.

Jack turned to his team. "Carter. Tell the agents in place to fall back to… this crossing here. Cover the tunnel exits in range."

"Yes, Sir." She tapped her radio and started talking in a low voice.

"If they're bolting, we should expect a trap or self-destruct in the building," Catra said. Jack could hear the 'it's what I would do' she left unsaid.

"Yes," Hordak said, nodding. "Depriving the enemy of your resources is a sound strategy."

“I’ll bow to your experience as evil warlords,” Jack said before he could help himself. Catra seemed to flinch for a moment, but that might’ve been his imagination. Hordak, though, merely nodded.

“So, let’s drop SG-3 right on their spots,” Adora said, pointing at the locations. “Then we drop down behind the main part of the runners.”

The ship was already moving - to Jack, it still felt wrong to see how the ship dived and banked, yet not feel any g-forces at all. The fighters you could construct with such technology…

“We’re at the first SG-3 drop zone! Disembarking troops!” Adora announced.

Jack was still staring at the spreading dots on the map. He was pretty sure there was a leader amongst them. But where would they be? If it was a Goa’uld, they wouldn’t be with the main force headed towards Seattle. They would use the distraction to escape in another direction. Unless they were planning a double-bluff.

“We’re at the second drop spot!”

More troops from SG-3 charged out of the ship. And one small group of dots on the map was inside the main escape tunnel somehow - the one not connected to the building. How had they managed that? But those might be the leader and his entourage…

“If it’s a Goa’uld, they might be counting on taking over one of our troops,” Catra said. “We wouldn’t be able to find them easily if they’re near Goa’uld technology.”

Jack looked at her. That made… a lot of sense for one of the snakes. “Only if they know how we found them.” The NID team might not have been privy to that information. On the other hand, it didn’t take a genius to suspect scanners.

“How else would we have found them? The timing will make them suspect it.”

“Yes.” Jack looked at the map again. “And that means you’re right - they will attempt to hide amongst us.” he looked at Carter. “Captain, inform Major Warren that his men have to keep a strict distance from any enemy. There is a high risk of Goa’ulds trying to take them over.”

“Yes, Sir.”

“But…” Daniel shook his head, pressing his lips together.

Jack nodded. He knew as well as his friend did that the odds of SG-3 taking many prisoners weren’t good to begin with, but this would make them even more trigger-happy. They had a number of zats, but not nearly enough for every soldier.

“We’re at the third drop spot!”

The remaining members of SG-3 rushed out, Warren waving at the ship as she lifted off again.

“Take the main force in the flank and roll them up?” Adora suggested. “I can draw their fire.”

Jack hesitated - sending a girl, a young woman, ahead to draw fire went against his instincts. But She-Ra was basically a walking main battle tank. So he nodded. “Yes.”

“Darla, drop us at this spot! Then hover above the area and…” Adora turned to Entrapta. “We need you to keep track of all Naquadah in the area.”

“I can do that!” Apparently, Entrapta was still hyped on caffeine.

That would end in a nasty crash, in Jack’s experience. Unless they were magically immune or something. Or Entrapta had some alien drugs to avoid that.

It didn’t matter right now - Jack and his team rushed towards the airlock, followed by the Etherians.

“We should be covering the second group as well,” Bow said as the doors slid open, and Jack heard the sound of automatic weapons.

“We’re tracking them,” Catra said. “We shouldn’t split up.”

“Never split the party,” Jack joked as he jumped off the ramp, clenching his teeth in anticipation of the strain on his knees - and blinked when he touched the ground. He felt perfectly fine. No strain at all. Hell, he felt as good as he had in his youth. How the…? He pushed the thought away. He could ask Adora later about her healing. Time to focus on bagging a snake.

He gripped his M4 as they rushed from the ship into the closest cover - a bunch of trees near a small mound.

*****

Outside Seattle, United States of America, Earth, August 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora easily outpaced the others, taking the lead. That was her duty - she was She-Ra, Princess of Power. And with power came responsibility. The others couldn’t shrug off bullets and energy blasts. She-Ra could. She had to protect everyone else.

She jumped through the tightly-clustered cove of trees, slashing with her sword, and landed on the ground behind it, sword held out at her side. Behind her, two trees toppled to the ground, granting cover for her friends.

Something moved ahead of her, leaning out behind a tree and firing at her. Adora moved her sword, parrying most of a burst from a rifle, two bullets bouncing off her chest and shoulder. The man in white robes kept firing at her until he ran dry. As soon as he started to swap the magazine, Adora rushed forward, driving her fist into his stomach. Gently, of course - she didn’t want to kill him.

He collapsed, and she quickly checked for a pouch. But then two more opened up on her, one with a zat'nik'tel. The first shot missed her as she charged the other shooter, but the second shot hit her back - and she felt that. Like an itch under her skin.

Hissing, she knocked down the first man. Then she whirled and jumped over the next shot, landing near the shooter, and grabbed his hand before he could line up another shot. "I'll be taking that," she told him.

He tried to get his hand free, then reached for his rifle, slung over his back, with his free hand, so she slammed him into the tree behind him. One more down, and…

A long burst ripped through the tree and the man, blood splattering over her as she dove to the side out of reflex. That was a support weapon! And that could spell the end for her friends. Where was it?

She turned around. There! Cleverly hidden in a bush. She just had to…

The bush exploded. Adora jerked back, then stared. Two bodies were on the ground, thrown away by the explosion. Who had…?

Ah. Jack and the rest of SG-1 were moving on her flank. That meant she had been too slow - she was the point to draw fire and get the enemies to reveal themselves.

Adora clenched her teeth and charged ahead. They were already reaching the firefight between SG-3 and those people. She passed a dead body on the ground, knocked out another behind cover, then started to roll up the flank. One flank - this was a chaotic mess, like fighting in the Whispering Woods. It seemed the frontlines were disappearing as the white-robed people charged into melee range. And they rushed at SG-3 but weren't trying to break through.

"They really want to get close," she said. Catra had been right.

Well, that gave her an idea. She grinned as she jumped into the middle of the largest battle, driving her sword into the ground as she landed and sending the robed people sprawling. "Surrender!" she yelled.

"Get her!" someone screamed. "Get her for your God!"

All the robed people nearby rushed towards her, yelling incoherently. Some were shooting, and she deflected a few bullets and zat'nik'tel shots with her sword, but most seemed to want to punch her - or grapple her.

Adora grinned as she started knocking them out and around. The shooting had stopped as well, at least near her. One managed to grab her from behind, but an elbow into his gut sent him to the ground, retching. Another threw punches and kicks she didn't feel at all - he wouldn't have made it through Horde training like that. She grabbed his throat and squeezed gently until he passed out while she kicked a knife out of another's hand.

More shots rang out - SG-3 and SG-1 were firing - and she saw another man collapse, clutching his guts.

For a moment, the others froze. Then they howled and seemed to lose their minds. People blindly rushed forward, shooting in every direction - someone tried to bite her ankle! This was…

Someone bit her neck? She reached around and… grabbed a snake. No, a Goa'uld! She gasped as she held the squirming, hissing thing in her hand.

A Goa'uld on Earth!

"I've got a Goa'uld!" she yelled.

"Get it to us!" Jack yelled back. "Cover her!"

'Cover her'? She scoffed and jumped, then rushed away from the still howling mob. Jack and the others were… There!

A quick dash through another cove, and she slid behind the fallen tree Jack and the rest of SG-1 were using as cover, holding out her prisoner to him.

He recoiled with a grimace. “Watch it!”

“It’s not going to escape,” she assured him.

“Carter, get the snake carrier.”

“It’s a containment unit, Sir.”

“It’s meant to carry a snake to the pound. A snake carrier.”

Whatever. Adora stuffed the snake into the container and closed the lid before it could attempt to escape.

Sam quickly sealed it. “There could be more,” she said.

Before Adora could answer, an explosion shook the ground. She looked up - the resort had blown up. Parts were flying through the air.

“Watch out!” Jack yelled as everyone dived for cover.

Catra has been right about that as well, Adora thought as she stared at the flying debris and raised her sword.

*****

Samantha Carter threw herself behind the closest tree just as the shockwave arrived and was blown off slightly, hitting the ground harder than intended. She rolled with it anyway and rushed forward to hide behind the trunk. The debris launched up by the explosion would be starting to come down about now, and even a little cover was better than none, even though Sam didn’t like her chances to…

A blinding beam close by made her gasp and shield her eyes. Blinking, she realised it was Adora, sword held with both hands,

pointed at the sky above them - at the expanding cloud of dust and smoke.

At the debris starting to rain down on them.

Sam stared as the concrete and wood fragments falling towards them were vaporised in the … magic beam.

"Well, looks like Magical Princess She-Ra just saved our bacon again," the Colonel commented next to her as he slowly got up.

"I think that might be an actual title, Jack," Daniel said, still cowering behind a felled tree trunk.

"Indeed."

The Colonel tapped his radio. "SG-3, report!" He tapped the radio again. "Entrapta, any movement on the scanner?"

"Uh… none any more. The group in the tunnel stopped moving short of leaving the tunnel. And the exit is now open."

Sam pressed her lips together - if the explosion had originated underground, and the lack of a massive shockwave indicated that, and someone had been in the tunnels there…

"Fried Goa'uld, anyone?" the Colonel asked.

Before Sam could react, SG-3's report came in. One dead, two wounded, two stunned.

"Jack! We'll have to check everyone for Goa'uld possession!"

Sam almost expected the Colonel to make a joke about them now being in possession of a Goa'uld, but the Colonel just nodded. And she berated herself, briefly, for thinking of such a cruel joke - Daniel's wife was still a Goa'uld host.

"Everyone OK? I can heal!" Adora looked around.

“We’ve got two wounded, and I think the cultists need some healing,” the Colonel replied.

Those who hadn’t been killed already.

“On it!”

Sam opened a channel to Entrapta. “We need a map of all Naquadah concentrations.” If there were more Goa’uld around, and if they started to go after people who weren’t as tough as She-Ra…

“Teal’c! Start collecting the zat’nik’tels!” The Colonel must have had the same thought. Teal’c was the obvious choice to collect the weapons - he could repel an attempt to possess him thanks to his superhuman reflexes.

Adora went towards SG-3, but Catra went after her. “Adora! What were you thinking?”

“What?”

“You were almost possessed by a Goa’uld!”

“It couldn’t even dent my skin!”

Sam shook her head. Adora in She-Ra form was… Apparently, she had shrugged off bullets from an M2 Browning heavy machine gun.

But they had a mission to do. With Entrapta’s help, she directed Teal’c to the scattered Goa’uld weapons - only zat’nik’tels, no staff weapons - while Adora healed the wounded and the Colonel and Daniel started towards the smoking ruins of the resort with the Etherians.

Then she joined the others. “I told you so,” Catra said. “Blew up the whole bunker.” She flashed her teeth. “They destroyed most of their tech rather than letting us get it.”

“Great. Wanna bet that the Russians won’t believe us?” The Colonel shook his head.

“Sir. Naquadah is resistant enough so advanced technology could’ve survived the explosion intact,” Sam pointed out. “It was a conventional explosive.” Her radiation detectors weren’t showing any reaction, at least.

“Yeah, blowing up the evil lair once the villain’s dead is kind of a convention.”

“Jack!”

“Daniel.”

“The Goa’uld might have hoped to make us think that the technology was destroyed, to return later to recover it. Much later,” she added when Daniel opened his mouth.

“Well, they won’t unless they can escape a snake carrier. But I guess we’ll have to ask Adora to play excavator again.”

That was a better and faster solution than waiting for an excavation team with both the clearance and the skill to deal with advanced technology. But to ask Adora…

“Just tell her,” Glimmer said. “Hey! Adora! We need you to dig a hole here!” she yelled.

A minute later, Adora appeared, jogging towards them. “I was just finishing healing the others,” she said.

Catra huffed, and Adora glanced at her before going on: “Entrapta didn’t find any more Naquadah than the weapons Teal’c collected. Outside the building - the ruins - at least.”

And there was Teal’c. “SG-3 is guarding the prisoners and the weapons,” he said. “But they had trouble recovering the prisoner glued to a tree.”

Bow grinned a little sheepishly. “I can use a catalyst to undo that.”

“I ripped the tree out,” Adora replied. “So… where do I need to dig?”

The other Etherians just pointed at the ruins.

Adora blinked.

“Just consider it punishment for letting a Goa’uld touch you,” Catra said. “Really! You’ve become sloppy!”

“What?”

“Enough!” Glimmer shook her head. “We need to secure whatever wasn’t destroyed by the blast.”

Sam nodded. Even if the artefacts were destroyed, the Naquadah was extremely valuable and could be extracted.

And they had to ensure that there were no other Goa’uld around. And that meant recovering and identifying every Naquadah concentration.

*****

Outside Seattle, United States of America, Earth, August 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“You sound like you’re enjoying yourself. Should I be concerned about being replaced by debris?” Catra flashed her fangs in a grin when Adora stopped heaving rubble and concrete remains around and blushed.

“Hey! It’s not like that!”

“So you claim. But you didn’t sound like that when you were burying the gate.”

“That was just earth, not rubble like this!” Adora retorted.

"So, I should be concerned…"

"What? No!"

"Oh, knock it off, you two! You're holding up the recovery operation!" Glimmer the spoilsport cut in. "It's already late."

"Someone's jealous…" Catra half-whistled.

As expected, that earned her a glare from Glimmer. "I'm not jealous! I just don't think we should waste any more time here. We need to recover the remaining Naquadah."

"Before it turns out to be a bomb," Bow added loyally.

That was a possibility, but Catra didn't think it was a likely one. The Goa'uld hadn't struck her as suicidal, and if he had been, the Naquadah would have probably gone off with the first explosion.

Still, they were right. "You heard them, Adora. Stop wasting time!"

"What? *I* am wasting time?" Adora stared at her.

"Yes."

"But…"

"Get shovelling!" And maybe you won't have to do too much grovelling later when we're going to talk some more about how you shouldn't let body-snatching aliens touch you, Catra added in her head.

Adora huffed and started digging again. And Catra sat down on a piece of conveniently sized and placed concrete and looked at the rest of the site. At least SG-3's men - all men, she had noted - had stopped staring openly at Adora. Some still sneaked glances, though. "Looks like your friends didn't believe you about Adora," she commented to Daniel, who was examining a burnt book nearby.

“Huh?” He blinked and turned his head, and she repeated herself with a nod towards the other American soldiers. “Oh.” He nodded. “Yes. I think they thought that we were exaggerating in our reports.” With a frown, he added: “We select Stargate Command staff for mental flexibility, but I think magical princesses were a bit too much for our marines.”

“The Horde was full of rather dull people,” Catra said, “but they wouldn’t have questioned your reports.” She stretched a little.

“But they were used to magic and princesses,” he retorted. “Our people aren’t. For most, this sounds like a fairy tale. Or a cartoon.”

Made-up stories, in other words. Or Lies. “Well, they better change views,” Catra told him. “Because we can’t really fight a war effectively if shared information isn’t trusted.”

“On the other hand,” he said, “blind obedience isn’t a good thing either. You need a balance between scepticism and trust.”

“Trust but verify?” She grinned.

“Well, you can’t really verify our reports independently, not as a soldier. They don’t have the time or opportunity.”

“Until they enter combat with us.”

“Yes. And I think you made an impression. There’ll probably be some hero-worship amongst a few of them.”

Catra shook her head. “As long as they don’t cause trouble.”

He chuckled. “Jack would say that they are marines - they will cause trouble. Especially if they’re bored.”

She sighed. “I wonder how you managed to run your army for so long with such people.”

“It worked out well - especially against enemies that prized blind loyalty and obedience.”

“Well, that…” Catra started to retort when Adora’s yell cut her off.

“I found it!”

Catra stood and began to walk over, but Entrapta was already running, Sam not too far behind. “Oh! What is it? It can’t be a Stargate, or they would have used it to flee, but it’s too big for a weapon, and… Oh! That looks fascinating!”

“It is a ring transporter,” Teal’c said, peering at the remains Adora was pointing at. “Or it was a ring transporter.”

“What? No fancy Egyptian name?” O’Neill asked.

“Well, the direct translation would be…” Daniel started to explain, but O’Neill cut him off. “Ring transporter is fine. I would hate to use more accents in my reports. “So, seen this before.”

“On Abydos,” Daniel agreed. “I wonder where this one led to.”

“A transporter? Oh! That would explain how they got into the tunnel without an opening!” Entrapta nodded. Several times. Then she yawned. “Clever!”

“But to use such a transporter for a few yards?” Daniel shook his head.

“If you have it, why wouldn’t you use it?” O’Neill shrugged. “But it’s broken.”

“But we can still study it - and find out how to copy it!” Entrapta beamed. Then she suddenly frowned. “But… can we examine it without causing trouble with the United Nations?”

That was a good question, in Catra’s opinion. “I think they’re mainly concerned about you taking it for yourselves,” she said, looking at O’Neill.

“They’re kinda insecure like that, yes,” he replied.

"Jack! We're talking international politics, not…" Daniel shook his head.

"Same thing, Daniel. They want what we have and don't want us to have more than they have." O'Neill tilted his head. "Kinda like it was in the Cold War, actually."

"The Cold War cannot be reduced to such simplified propaganda. It was much more complex, and…"

"I just did."

Catra shook her head at the men's antics. Daniel was probably right - the United Nations would want to have a say about this.

At least the presence of a Goa'uld should make most of the idiots realise how dangerous the whole situation was.

*****

Stargate Command, Colorado, August 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and we recovered the rest of the remains - both Naquadah and human - from the tunnel. It looks like the group trying to escape were all humans sent out as a distraction," Jack O'Neill said. He didn't bother to hide his scowl - according to Carter, the bomb had been triggered by the hatch of the escape tunnel opening. "The Goa'uld - named Setesh as far as we can tell - had planned to take over one of SG-3's men to hide amongst them."

"Do you have any proof for that?" General Hammond asked.

"The tactics, Sir," Jack replied at once. "He sent his guards against SG-3 to 'wipe out the enemies of their god', not to break through their lines to escape. And they were ordered to do so in melee range, not by using the prepared positions and ambushes on their land. His orders all but guaranteed that they would be wiped out."

"They fought from prepared positions, though."

"Only at the beginning, and then only with the heavy machine guns," Jack retorted. "Those wouldn't have been easy to move ahead."

"But as soon as he would have taken over a soldier, he would have been at risk from his own people," Hammond pointed out.

"Yes. But I think Setesh took a calculated risk." The Goa'uld was a bastard but no coward.

Hammond didn't seem to be convinced. "What about the survivors?"

"They're fanatics. And those who were taken alive tried to kill themselves for 'failing their god'." And they only had been able to take some of the cultists alive thanks to zats and, of course, She-Ra. "It looks like a cult problem. I guess we'll have to call in specialists. At least we can do that now without worrying too much about secrecy."

Hammond frowned. "We're still dealing with sensitive information here. But our pool of available specialists was widened by the revelation of the Stargate."

"They might also have been drugged, Sir," Carter cut in. "When we were running tests for poison, we detected an unidentified foreign substance in their blood."

"Yeah. Our local West Coast god pulled all the tricks of his human competitors," Jack said. Drugs, sex and what a Goa'uld thought was rock'n'roll.

"He might have actually been the inventor of some of those 'tricks'," Daniel said. "I've been looking into this, and I think I have identified two earlier cults ran by the Goa'uld. Both ended in mass suicides. If you can call it a suicide when a leader orders his brainwashed followers to die." He patted a stack of sheets on the table. "I'm working on a timeline, but I suspect that the Goa'uld was on Earth since Ra's departure - the names he used point towards that."

“We’ve had a Goa’uld on Earth for millennia, and he didn’t take over?” Hammond asked.

“He must have been afraid of Ra,” Daniel replied, “and kept a low profile. I assume we can get more information once we manage to interrogate him.”

“Yes. Your suggestion of granting the Goa’uld an animal as host so they can write or use a computer to communicate.” Hammond nodded. “It hasn’t been approved yet.”

“Why not?” Jack asked with a frown. “Did PETA veto it? Or did the Etherians mention that monkeys have rights on their planet?”

“No, Colonel. But the government is concerned about security and the optics of having a Goa’uld possess a monkey.” Hammond explained. Or not.

“They think we’d let a monkey escape? Do they think this is Disneyland?” Jack shook his head.

“‘Optics’, General?” Daniel asked. “Are they worried that people will have sympathies for the Goa’uld if it’s in a monkey’s body?”

“In a word, yes, Dr Jackson.” Hammond grimaced. “They’re worried that showing a small fuzzy animal using a computer will send the wrong message about the danger the Goa’uld present to Earth and humanity. And yes, some members of the cabinet voiced concerns about the public perception of sacrificing an ‘innocent animal’ to the alien invaders.”

Jack groaned. “Can’t we just pick an ugly animal then?”

“You would be surprised how many people would still care.” Hammond sighed.

“Are you talking about your granddaughters, General?” Carter asked.

"They wanted a pot-bellied pig after the last nature documentary they watched," Hammond said. "And they refused to eat meat for a week."

Jack groaned again. Since when did the government care about the opinions of little children? Would they ban broccoli at schools next?

"What about the international reactions, Sir?" Carter asked.

Hammon sighed once more. That was a bad sign. "As expected, the Security Council is moving to claim control over all technology we recovered. But some states also suspect that we didn't report everything we found, citing the lack of international observers. And some even suspect that this was staged to improve our position and image."

Great. "And what about Russia and China?" Jack asked.

"They haven't made their position known so far, except for supporting international control over alien technology." Hammond smiled a little weakly. "Pressure on Egypt and Honduras is increasing, and they haven't had access to the results from the scan Captain Carter and Princess Entrapta did, but that hasn't stopped either country from having their armed forces search for advanced technology."

Jack sighed himself. The Etherians would just love this.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, August 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"You think this is a hoax?" Adora blurted out. She winced a little at the glance Glimmer stent towards her. Her friend was supposed to handle this, but Adora hadn't managed to control herself. "Twenty people died! And you think this was a hoax?" she spat.

The delegate from a minor country shook her head. "I merely pointed out how convenient this whole incident was. The Security Council is debating an unprecedented infraction against every nation's sovereignty, and suddenly, there's an emergency that would seem to demonstrate the urgency that was put in doubt by cooler heads?"

"We captured a Goa'uld who had been hiding on Earth for centuries!" Adora retorted. "And we secured a lot of their technology! Weapons technology!"

"So you claim," the woman said. "So far, there has been no proof presented to us."

"And the technology was secured by the United States," the Russian delegate added.

"Because the incident happened on our soil and the Security Council hasn't made any decision yet about the status of alien technology recovered on Earth," the American delegate said.

"How convenient for you." The Russian sneered for a moment.

"As if you're not already looking for the artefact in Siberia," the American shot back.

"It's really like an Alliance meeting in the bad old days," Adora heard Glimmer mutter. Then her friend cleared her throat. "We have records of the battle. And we took a count of all the technology secured by us."

"By you? Do you include yourself in the American forces now?" Another delegate asked.

"It was a joint-force action," Glimmer told him. "The Princess Alliance isn't beholden to anyone but will work with anyone against the Goa'uld."

The Chinese delegate spoke up: "But the fact that the United States secured this technology raises some concerns about the

sincerity of their stated willingness to cooperate with the rest of the world."

"So far, the rest of the world hasn't even been able to agree on a course of action," the American retorted.

"And the longer we wait, the greater the danger - we don't know what is hidden at the other locations," Glimmer said. "If there's another Goa'uld active on Earth, then they might have already infiltrated a local government."

"Is that going to be your excuse for violating a nation's sovereignty? A supposed threat of being controlled by an alien parasite?" Another of the smaller country's delegates asked with a scowl.

Glimmer frowned in return. "No. The only excuse we need to intervene is the fact that Goa'uld technology could indicate a Goa'uld base or operation."

They really didn't like hearing that, Adora saw.

"If it's so urgent, why haven't you told Honduras and Egypt the exact locations of the technology you detected inside their territories?"

"Because they have neither the experience nor the technology to handle the kind of threats that the Goa'uld represent," Glimmer said.

"Which you should know if you'd read our report!" Adora added. She had spent hours writing it! Daniel was right - it was very annoying if you wrote a report and no one read it.

"Anyone can claim anything in a report. We need actual proof. Show us this 'Goa'uld'!"

Several delegates nodded at that - not just the smaller countries.

“And the technology!” another delegate added. “We need to see if there’s any truth to this supposed danger.”

“Fine!” Glimmer spat. “We’ll show you the technology and the Goa’uld.”

“And I think we should talk to the Goa’uld,” the Chinese delegate added.

“The Goa’uld cannot talk unless they control a human body,” Adora pointed out.

“Then get a volunteer. We can secure the body so they cannot escape.”

“We haven’t found a safe way to remove a Goa’uld from a human host yet,” Entrapta said, looking up from her computer. “They can excrete a poison that kills the host when they’re removed. We’re looking into ways to bypass that, but we’ve just started.”

The Chinese delegate frowned. “What about using a condemned criminal?”

Adora gasped. They wanted to…kill a person for this? Or just… leave the person a prisoner in their own body?

Other delegates were shocked as well.

“You can’t be serious!”

“That’s barbaric!”

“This goes against everything we stand for!”

But the Chinese delegate stood his ground. “Barbaric? I’ll remind you that the death penalty is legal in the United States. There’s nothing barbaric about this - someone about to be executed might even volunteer for this.”

“That’s… no civilised country could condone this!” another delegate objected.

Hordak nodded - Adora saw he was tenser than normal. “It would be torture for the person, and I’ve been told that torture is outlawed on Earth.”

‘Cruel and unusual punishment’, Daniel had called it on the flight back to Colorado.

“Yes. We could use an animal as a host, I guess,” Entrapata added. She had finally slept on the flight back, but Adora was still concerned about her. She would have to make sure that her friend got a full night’s sleep after this.

“An animal?”

“Yes. Like an ape - they are close to humans. He wouldn’t be able to speak, but they could use a keyboard,” Entrapta explained.

“We would be interrogating an ape?” the Chinese delegate seemed to be surprised.

“The optics of that would be… questionable,” another delegate said.

“Many apes are an endangered species,” another objected.

“One more or less won’t doom a species.”

“Cruelty to animals isn’t a good thing either.”

“That the West cares more about animals than the people living in the developing countries is well-known.”

“Now wait a minute! This isn’t about animal rights!”

“Indeed. It’s about human rights - and nations’ rights!”

Adora blinked as another pointless argument started. “We should just have gone straight to the other locations,” she muttered.

*****

Stargate Command, Colorado, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Why didn't we land the spaceship yet? We already have dozens of those zat'nik'tels!"

Samantha Carter pressed her lips together - facing away from Dr Davis so the scientist wouldn't notice. They had gone over this already. "General Hammond explained that landing a working faster-than-light spaceship under our control in the United States has been deemed to be ill-advised in the current political situation," she reminded him.

"But we're scientists, not politicians!"

Sam didn't have to turn to know the man was pouting. "Which means we leave international politics to the experts and listen to them when it concerns their field." Even though the politicians might not always listen to scientists when it concerned science.

"But this doesn't concern them! The ship is ours! The Etherians agreed! And it wasn't recovered on any foreign soil but in space! There's no other claim on it!"

Sam had been there when the ship had been recovered. She sighed, not bothering to hide her annoyance any longer, and turned to stare at Davis - who seemed surprised at her reaction. "That is a matter of debate," she told him. "There's substantial support in the United Nations to internationalise the entire Stargate Command."

"But that's just posturing! We'll just veto whatever resolution they come up with! That's how the UN works! Why do we let them keep us from working on an actual spaceship?"

Sam was tempted to call Daniel to explain things to Davis. Even if Davis was ignoring facts outside his expertise, Daniel might be able to talk until Davis agreed with him just to be able to get back

to work. But Daniel was needed in the examination and possible interrogation of the Goa'uld they had captured.

She should have volunteered to assist there, Sam realised, instead of examining the recovered technology. On the other hand, if that had left Davis in charge, they might end up missing something crucial. The man had the needed clearance for work at Stargate Command, but he wasn't ready to take such responsibility. She almost snorted at the thought that this must have been how Russian scientists had felt when working with 'politically reliable' 'colleagues' instead of the best experts in the field.

"That was how it worked before the arrival of aliens," she reminded Davis. "Things changed. The United States can't afford to act unilaterally right now." Perhaps never again, depending on how things might develop.

"But… the law's clear! We can veto anything the United Nations decide! Anything substantial, at least!"

"This isn't a matter of law, but politics," Sam explained as she put the zat'nik'tel she had been examining down on the table. "And if the United States would act as you suggest, the political and economic consequences would be harsh." Daniel had gone on about that a length after a joke by the Colonel. "In the current crisis, the country cannot afford that."

"But we've got a spaceship! If we figure out how to build more of them, we don't need anyone else - we can colonise space! Boldly go where no one has gone before! And with the second Stargate we have, we could just pick a planet and establish a private network!"

That wasn't how it worked - well, they could, in theory, use irises on both gates and only ever open and accept connections to the two gates - but… "Do you honestly think that the rest of the world and the Etherians would let the United States monopolise the gates like that? And how do you think we could afford to build enough spaceships to protect the country and the colony with the

rest of the world opposed to this? If we actually find a habitable planet that hasn't been colonised by the Goa'uld already. Or by another species."

"But…" He trailed off. "Why would the Etherians care?"

Oh for…! "Have you somehow missed that they have explicitly stated that they do not recognise the United States as the single representative of Earth?"

He looked honestly confused. "But… everyone knows that's just window dressing. They've been working with us, and with no one else, haven't they?"

"They have been working with us because we met them," she explained. "And because we have a common enemy. But they won't support us against the rest of the world if we want to monopolise the gate." She snorted. "Certainly not if we can't legalise gay marriage." She wasn't going to mention polygamy at this point.

That seemed to shock him. "But…" He shook his head. "But that's just their starting position! As long as we get rid of 'don't ask, don't tell', we're fine!"

What? She glared at him. "What gave you this absurd idea? This isn't their starting position - the Etherians aren't going to compromise on that." How could Davis think this? This was… "Wait!" She narrowed her eyes at him. "Do others share your views?" This needed to be corrected at once! If the politicians listened to those people…

"Uh…"

But before he could answer, the phone rang. Sam picked it up. "Captain Carter."

It was the Colonel. And he sounded… upset. "Carter? We need you upstairs. Someone just blew up part of Egypt."

*****

The Naquadah Crisis Part 3

Above the Mediterranean, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

As Darla approached Egypt after picking up SG-1 in Colorado, everyone gathered on the bridge. Catra looked around - Adora was looking grim, but that was normal. Glimmer was scowling, which was also normal. O'Neill looked tense, which was… not normal.

"This was recorded by one of the ships in orbit," Entrapta, who had recovered from her collapse after her 'concentrated tea' ran out, explained as she pointed at the large screen showing a patch of desert. A patch of desert with a camp of Earth troops in it, surrounding some ruins on the ground. "It shows the location of the explosion - before it exploded, of course." She pushed a button with her hair, and the image zoomed in.

"Better resolution than our own satellites," Catra heard O'Neill mutter. Well, did he expect anything else?

Catra had seen the record before, but she still studied it. Earth tanks - four of them - were lined up at the edge of the camp. Smaller vehicles drove around them, and a lot of people walked all over the place. "Aren't those American tanks?" she asked, knowing the answer.

"It's the export variant of the M1-Abrams Main Battle Tank," Carter replied.

"The monkey model," O'Neill added.

"That means it's a more primitive version of the American model," Daniel said.

Adora cleared her throat, and Entrapta continued. "Four hours ago, the whole area exploded."

Behind her, the desert, camp and ruins on the screen vanished in a cloud of smoke and fire. The picture zoomed back to show the size of the cloud. It was huge.

"Entrapta and I have independently come to the conclusion that the power of the explosion is beyond what could have been achieved with conventional explosives based on Earth technology," Carter said. "Not to mention that the sheer mass of explosives needed for such an explosion would have strained the logistics of the Egyptian Army. On the other hand, the scanners do not show any radioactive fallout, though, which should be present if this was a nuclear explosion. In any case, the immediate shockwave barely missed the outskirts of Cairo. But part of the 6th of October City was devastated. Civilian casualties are still being tallied up but expected to be in the thousands."

And that was why everyone looked so grim. If the bomb had gone off a little closer… Cairo had, what, millions of people? Hell, the panic from the bomb probably killed as many as the bomb itself - they had seen pictures showing desperate people trying to flee the city…

The Security Council had declared this an international emergency and possible alien attack and assumed authority over the whole affair. Egypt hadn't protested, as far as Catra had heard - Darla had already been on the way to Colorado by then.

"Do we have more information about the cause of this?" Daniel asked.

"Well, we've narrowed the origin down to this structure," Entrapta told him. A building buried in the sand replaced the crater on the screen.

"That's the Desert Tempel of Osiris," Daniel said at once. "But it was empty when it was discovered fifty years ago - plundered by grave robbers." Everyone looked at him, and he shrugged as if he were embarrassed. Well, he might actually be. "It's just one of many such buildings that were left looted. It showed up on our

scan with the field of tombs nearby, but I tagged it as a low priority since they were known."

"Well, apparently, it wasn't as empty as people thought," O'Neill said. "And it seems the Egyptians sent soldiers to every ruin in the country that showed up on your scan. Someone must have tipped them off."

"We shared the data with the Security Council, Sir," Carter pointed out.

"I know." O'Neill frowned. "We shouldn't have done that. The United Nations leak like a sieve."

"But we had a leak as well - that's why the NID went to Setesh's base," Daniel retorted. O'Neill glared at him, but he shrugged in return. "Just saying, Jack."

Adora cleared her throat again. "So… do we know what triggered the explosion? We didn't get any data before we left to fetch you."

"We don't have any information yet either," Carter replied. "It could've been an automated defence mechanism left by the Goa'uld."

"You can call it a trap, Carter," O'Neill cut in.

She glanced at him. "That is the most likely explanation. It is theoretically possible that someone brought a nuclear bomb in there, but to generate an explosion of this power, it would have been too large to conceal from any guard - or it would have been a Naquadah-enhanced nuclear device."

Which on Earth, only the Americans were supposed to have, Catra knew.

"We've ruled out a missile, artillery barrage or airstrike," Hordak took over. "Although that is based on the assumption that no force on Earth can defeat our sensors."

And that, in turn, was based on the information SG-1 gave them. Catra looked at the Americans.

"To our knowledge, no country has such a capability," O'Neill said.

"Some of the media in the region blame Israel," Glimmer pointed out.

O'Neill groaned. "Of course they would."

"Israel and Egypt are at peace," Daniel said.

"Not everyone is happy about that," O'Neill retorted. "A lot of people would be happy if Egypt and Israel went at it again. And while I think we can dismiss an Israeli airstrike, I don't doubt that Israel's government would be happier if the Egyptians don't have advanced technology."

Ah. Catra hadn't studied that conflict in detail, but she had learned enough from an overview that she understood him.

"Other media claim that this was our work," Entrapta said. "A lot of them in the region, actually. They claim that we destroyed the technology before it could be secured by the Egyptians."

"But we said that this was up to the United Nations to decide." Adora shook her head.

"They don't trust us. Or they want us to look bad," Glimmer said.

"And then there are the media who claim that this was the work of a god, removing 'satan's temptation' before it corrupts the faithful," Bow added.

Catra shook her head. Earth people were weird. Very weird.

*****

West of Cairo, Egypt, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“That’s one big crater.” Jack O’Neill shook his head. “Well, if everything else fails, they can fill it with water and turn the area into a resort.”

No one laughed. Daniel made that interrupted gasping noise, Carter would be frowning at him for a moment, and Teal’c was more silent than usual.

Well, it hadn’t been a good joke. And it wasn’t a pretty sight - they were standing at the edge of a huge crater. A bit away from the wrecked suburb of Cairo.

“Radiation is at safe levels,” Carter reported without looking up from her devices.

“Good to know,” Jack replied. Though they had known that already - they wouldn’t have landed so close to the crater if it were still radioactive.

“Oh, no!” “This looks bad.”

Adora and the others had arrived.

“The devastation is impressive. The damage to foundations by the shockwave travelling through the ground will probably need some special sensor to detect,” Entrapta commented as she leaned forward to look at the crater’s edge.

Jack looked back and saw a bunch of Egyptian soldiers approaching them. “Ah… you locked the spaceship, right?”

“Of course,” Catra replied. “We don’t want more of those idiots getting killed by trying to break into a spaceship.”

“We don’t know if that was the cause of the explosion,” Glimmer told her. “It could’ve been a Goa’uld facing capture and deciding to suicide.”

“Or trying to fake his suicide,” Jack pointed out. Snakes were cunning, and any snake hiding in Egypt would have some sources

in the local government that would warn them about the scanners. Not that the scanner was a big secret any more - not after the Security Council had been informed. Jack expected the press to run some articles about it any day now. Probably wondering if that violated some privacy laws.

The Egyptian Humvee pulled up to a stop next to them, and a tall man - a colonel - got out, followed by another officer and two guards. "You! Are you in charge?" he snapped, staring at Jack.

"That depends on who you ask," Jack replied. "Colonel Jack O'Neill. Stargate Command."

The man's eyes widened. Who did he expect that the United States would send on this mission, anyway? The Navy?

"And I'm Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon," Glimmer spoke up. "Are you the officer in charge of the rescue operations?"

"What? No, I'm in charge of the security of the site!"

Jack pressed his lips together so he wouldn't crack a joke about the dire need a crater in the ground had for security. Hammond had been clear about the need to treat the locals with the utmost politeness - the Security Council had been anything but polite.

"You guard a hole in the ground? Someone in charge must hate you."

Obviously, Hammond hadn't told Catra that. The catwoman grinned at the Egyptian.

"You're the alien," the colonel - he still hadn't introduced himself, which was beginning to look less rude and more suspicious - replied.

"We're all aliens," Entrapta replied with a huge smile. "Although it depends on your definition - biologically, I think all of us except for Melog and Hordak could have fertile offspring with you without using genetic engineering. That means we're basically the same

species. But all of us were born on another planet, which means we're extraterrestrials!"

Jack briefly wondered if she had watched E.T. - few people used that word any more.

The Egyptian colonel, in any case, looked confused. "What?"

Entrapta repeated her explanation, which didn't seem to help at all. Especially not when she used her hair to handle another device - the soldiers really didn't like that.

Adora cleared her throat and stepped closer. "And I'm She-Ra, Princess of Power. We're here to help you. Do you have wounded in need of healing?"

All of the Egyptians stared at her. They probably hadn't expected her to be so freaking tall - Jack knew how imposing She-Ra looked when she was standing in front of you, and he was used to Teal'c towering over everyone.

But the Colonel shook his head. "Our doctors are handling the wounded," he said through clenched teeth. "We don't need your… magic."

"I wasn't aware that Earth medical science was as advanced as Etherian magic," Hordak commented.

"It isn't," Daniel told him.

"Then it seems ill-advised to refuse She-Ra's help. I can assure you that it's safe." Hordak smiled at the colonel. Or tried to - Jack had seen better smiles from greeters at Walmart shortly before closing time.

"I'm sure they have their reasons," Jack said. Like pride. Or they didn't want magic to be used on their countrymen.

"And what are your reasons?" Adora asked with a deep frown. "I can heal your wounded in an instant. Why would you want them

to take longer to heal up?"

"We can handle our problems ourselves," the man spat.

"Yeah, we can see that," Catra retorted, pointedly looking at the crater.

"The cause of the explosion hasn't been determined yet," Carter said.

One of the Egyptian soldiers muttered something - Jack thought it might have been 'sabotage'.

"Well, that's why we're here," Glimmer said. "To find out what happened and how to prevent similar accidents." She looked at the crater as well. "This can't be allowed to happen again."

The Egyptian Colonel snorted. "I'd like to see that."

"Well," the queen replied. "We'll be glad to show you. Are you our liaison, Mr…?"

"Colonel. Colonel Salah."

"Colonel Salah. We're here to secure the remaining potential artefacts left by the Goa'uld. For the United Nations," Glimmer said, smiling widely. "We were also here to help your rescue and recovery operations, but if you don't want our help with that, we can proceed to take control of the Naquadah."

The Colonel scowled in return. It was clear that he wanted them gone from the country.

Tough luck - the Security Council wasn't screwing around any more. Not after someone nuked part of Egypt - no one sane wanted this to happen to another country. Or that power in the hands of someone else.

*****

Those people were… Adora shook her head and pressed her lips together so she wouldn't blurt her thoughts out as they walked towards the centre of the crater. She knew that they couldn't alienate them. Not more than they already had, at least. Though the sheer stupidity grated on her. They had had a huge crater blown into their country, almost destroying their capital, and they still insisted they could handle it? They were worse than Catra had been at her worst.

She blinked and buried that thought. Catra wasn't like that any more. Not at all. And the local people would learn better as well. Hopefully without going through the same experiences as her lover.

And yet… people were suffering here for no other reason than pride. The pride of someone who wasn't hurt themselves, to boot. At least, that was Adora's assumption.

Entrapta waved her device around. "Radiation levels are normal for the area, I think. Nothing that would indicate that a fission-based bomb had gone off here," she announced. "Although it could've been a fusion bomb, of course - you have that technology."

"Even a fusion bomb would have needed a fission bomb to trigger," Sam added. "I think we can safely exclude the possibility of an Israeli strike with a nuclear weapon."

"I thought we already did that thanks to our surveillance from orbit?" Daniel asked.

"We did, but it's good to have confirmation, "Jack said.

"We need to tell the world so they stop blaming Israel for this," Glimmer said.

Adora nodded in agreement as she climbed over a broken rock the size of a cart. The protests she had seen on the television, aimed at both Israel and the Alliance…

“Yes, we should. And we will. But that won’t stop the claims,” Jack said.

“What?” Adora turned to look at him. He was standing on the rock she had just climbed over, then clenched his teeth and jumped down - and seemed surprised afterwards for some reason.

“Let me guess: It’s easier to blame foreign saboteurs than your own people, right?” Catra said, glancing over her shoulder at the Egyptians following them.

Adora did the same. Colonel Salah had fallen a bit back - he seemed to be struggling with the rocks in their way. The rest of his men didn’t seem to have such a problem but didn’t pass him. Which was fortunate since they might have heard Catra’s remark otherwise.

“Yeah,” Jack agreed. “Of course, we can’t exclude a Mossad operation with conventional explosives triggering a Goa’uld bomb - the last thing Israel wants is an Arab country with advanced technology.”

“But they are at peace with Egypt,” Adora pointed out, recalling the briefing. “They have been at peace for almost twenty years.” Almost as long as she had been alive.

“And the Egyptian leader at the time was murdered for making peace,” Jack said. “Not to mention that leaders change, and currently, everything’s changing.”

Once more, Adora pressed her lips together so she wouldn’t blurt out what she thought of that.

“I think there’s the epicentre,” Entrapta pointed out a little later. “It matches the geographic location, and the concentration of Naquadah in the environment shows a pattern that would support this.”

“Yes, the Naquadah that was all blown up and spread through the area,” Jack said, looking grim.

“Oh, don’t worry!” Entrapta smiled. “We can calibrate our scanners to ignore trace elements of Naquadah.”

“I was more concerned about the trace elements getting into people’s bodies. People such as us.”

Ew. Adora grimaced. She didn’t think that she had to worry, but Catra and the others?

“Oh, that shouldn’t reach any critical level. And we can purge it, I think - I would have to work out the details for a procedure, but it shouldn’t be too hard.”

They were at the lowest point of the crater now. And the ground…

“Glassed,” Daniel said.

“Yes. The heat must have been…” Sam mumbled something Adora didn’t catch. “If this wasn’t a nuclear bomb, then this had to have been a Naquadah-enhanced explosive, Sir.”

“Great. So, another suicide device by a snake?”

“In theory, you could create such an effect accidentally by using a conventional explosive near the right amount and isotope of Naquadah,” Sam explained. “Processed Naquadah is safe - the Goa’uld wouldn’t want to risk such explosions in combat - but there are certain isotopes that would be unstable enough to react to explosions.”

“An accidental nuke. Now we’ve seen everything.” Jack shook his head.

“We don’t know if that has happened here, Sir.”

“We’ll need more data to find out!” Entrapta announced. “But we should find traces of conventional explosives if those were used.” She cocked her head sideways. “Of course, if the soldiers here had explosives with them, we would find traces anyway, even if they didn’t use them.”

“So, in other words, we can’t find out if this was a Goa’uld trying to hide their tracks, or an accident, or sabotage?” Catra asked. She had lowered her voice, Adoara noticed - she must not want the Egyptians, who were arriving now, to hear this.

“That depends on the data we gather. There should be differences between explosives used to trigger Naquadah and explosives triggered by Naquadah. I think.” Entrapta was still smiling. “We might have to do some tests.”

“Right. Tests with Naquadah bombs.” Jack looked like he had bitten into something disgusting. “Let’s not do that right now. People get antsy if you want to blow up their country.”

“What?” Colonel Salah asked. He was huffing a little and red in the face.

“We were talking about tests to find out who blew up the area,” Entrapta told him. “We’ll have to find another location, then.”

“And we need to secure the other Naquadah artefacts in the country,” Catra reminded them.

Yes. Adora nodded again. That was what they were here for.

*****

Inside what she had come to think of their mobile lab in Darla’s hold, Samantha Carter peered at the readouts of their latest scan. “I think that’s as good as we can get,” she said.

“Yes. That should be all the Naquadah left that isn’t dust,” Entrapta agreed as she fiddled with the controls of the scanner.

“I concur,” Hordak added. He bent over the microphone and said: “No, to your left. The last artefact is to your left.”

“How do you know which way I am facing?” Adora’s voice came over the radio.

"We have the most advanced scanner on the planet," Hordak replied. "I can tell which way your hair is blowing."

"Big deal! That's where the wind blows!" another voice - Catra - cut in.

"Not if you take local conditions and windbreaks into account," Entrapta objected.

Sam stopped herself before becoming engaged in the discussion of windswept hair. The Colonel would never let her forget it. "Please focus on the recovery," she said instead.

"Why does it feel as if all I do is dig holes these days?" Adora complained.

"Because you're the best we have at that," Catra commented.

Neither the Colonel nor Daniel had spoken up, Sam realised. And this had been the perfect opening for a comment about archaeologists. "Sir?" she asked.

"Yes, Carter?"

He sounded as usual. Good. "What's the status of the Egyptians?" she asked. It was a logical question - Colonel Salah had been obviously unhappy to support them or their presence. And it was a good excuse as well.

"They're grumpy," the Colonel replied. *"But that's all so far. They haven't tried to take any Naquadah and squirrel it away, have they?"*

"Not according to our scanner," Sam replied.

"Good. Anything about the explosives?"

Sam pressed her lips together. "We're still analysing the samples." After a moment, she added: "I think that Entrapta is correct, and we need more testing to have a baseline. It wasn't as if they had

a lot of data about conventional explosives enhanced with Naquadah. "But we've identified the standard plastic explosive used by the Egyptian army," she added.

"Good."

It wasn't really helpful - a competent saboteur would have been able to use the same explosives, probably stolen or purchased from a corrupt officer - but it was another clue.

Although Sam had her doubts whether they would be able to find out for certain what, and who, caused the explosion. She glanced at the screen to the side, where several television programs were running. She was still leaning towards a breaching charge accidentally setting off Naquadah, but with several prominent religious leaders announcing that this was 'a sign of God's displeasure with the aliens and their blasphemous demands', it wasn't hard to imagine that this might have been a deliberate action by a fanatic amongst the soldiers. And she couldn't discount the saboteur hypothesis either. Or the failsafe.

"We got it! It's a… crushed zat," Bow announced over the radio.

"Great! That's the last piece then!" Entrapta replied. "We can move to the next site!"

"Finally!" Daniel's voice told Sam that he was pouting.

Well, it was understandable - the next 'site' was the Valley of the Kings. He was sure that the Naquadah artefacts their scan had shown would be in graves that hadn't been discovered so far. She chuckled - with the Stargate exposed, he could finally publish his findings, and this would be another feather in his cap, so to speak. And…

"Uh-oh!"

Entrapta sounded concerned. And that was, Sam had learned quickly after meeting the princess, a very bad sign. "What happened?" she asked.

“Darla said that there’s a large number of people moving towards us from the city.” Entrapta’s hair pointed at a screen showing a text, then started typing on the console next to it. “I think I can get a feed… there!”

The picture on the screen changed, showing a protest. No - a mob. She could see crude depictions of aliens hanging from gallows carried along. They must be blaming the Etherians for the explosion. “Colonel!” she snapped. “We’ve got a mob heading towards the ship and the crater. I suggest you evacuate the site.”

“We’re coming back! Everyone, pack up!” the Colonel snapped.

But they wouldn’t make it back in time. Sam pressed her lips together. “We need to pick them up.”

“I concur,” Hordak agreed. “Unless the screening forces use lethal force, I doubt they can stop this attack. Even with lethal force, I have my doubts.”

“Darla! Lift off!” Entrapta yelled as she headed out of the hold.

By the time Sam reached the bridge, the ship was hovering above the landing site. She couldn’t see any sign of the riot - or mob - headed their way, but the soldiers around them were restless. That could just be a reaction to the ship’s sudden movement, of course.

“We’re coming to you!” Entrapta said as Darla started flying westwards.

“You’ve heard her, folks! Get ready for the pick-up!” the Colonel ordered over the radio.

They reached the centre of the crater, now sporting more holes courtesy of Adora, in less than a minute, and Sam went to lower the ramp.

“Great to see you! Things were just getting boring,” the Colonel greeted her. “Everyone on board!”

"Colonel O'Neill! What are you doing?"

Colonel Salah had arrived, huffing - he must have hurried. His aide and the two soldiers with them were obviously in better shape.

"We're moving to the next site," the Colonel told the man.

"Before the mob gets here. Want a ride?" Glimmer added.

"Mob? What mob?" Salah blinked.

His aide checked the radio and paled, then said something in Arabic.

After a moment of gaping and looking over his shoulder and some quick back and forth in Arabic, Salah seemed to steel himself. "We will accompany you to the Valley of the Kings."

*****

Catra snorted at the officer's attitude as they boarded Darla. Salah made it sound as if this was some daring mission instead of him just coming along with them. Which, unless she was sorely mistaken, and she didn't think she was, would be what his orders said anyway.

Though, given the mob bearing down on them, maybe the colonel was worried about being attacked for siding with them? Either way, she'd keep an eye on him and his people - the possibility of saboteurs in the ranks of the Egyptian military was not negligible, after all.

And speaking of sabotage… She walked over to Entrapta, taking care to strut with her hands folded behind her head to appear bored, then whispered: "Did you scan Salah and his men for explosives?"

Entrapta blinked and looked at her, then at the two Egyptian soldiers, which were still sticking together near the ramp after

Salah and his aide had followed the others to the bridge. “You think… You think they might want to hurt Darla?”

“And us,” Catra added. “It’s a possibility. We still don’t know who caused the explosion here.”

“They aren’t carrying explosives,” Hordak cut in. “Not unless you count the propellant in their weapons, although even if they pooled all their ammunition, they wouldn’t be able to create a bomb that would be able to significantly damage a crucial component of Darla.”

That was a lot of qualifiers - too many for Catra’s taste - but Entrapta seemed satisfied. “I’ll still have Emily keep an eye on them!”

“Good.” Catra grinned as she passed the Egyptians on her way to the bridge. Emily bearing down on them should spook them enough to keep them from doing anything they shouldn’t do. The bot was a walking tank, especially after Entrapta and Hordak’s enhancements.

Her good mood vanished as soon as she entered the bridge, though, and saw Adora staring at the side screen with a grim expression. And with good reason - it showed the protesters attacking the soldiers. And the soldiers shooting them.

Catra didn’t whistle at the sight - Adora wouldn’t take any levity, even gallows humour, very well right now.

“Why are they doing this?” Adora asked. “Do they really blame us for the explosion?” She pressed her lips together.

“In a word: Yes.” O’Neill shrugged. “At least that’s what their signs say, though my Arabic is a little rusty.” He apparently couldn’t read Adora.

“It does say this on the signs, yes,” Daniel added.

And the various depictions of Catra and her friends hanging from gallows or being burned were a big clue as well, in Catra's opinion.

"They have been misled by traitors," Salah said. "But this wouldn't have happened if not for the… alien artefacts exploding."

"Or being blown up," O'Neill said. "So, let's avoid blowing up more artefacts and parts of Egypt, alright?"

Salah glared at him. "There won't be any saboteurs at this site."

"So you claim." O'Neill shrugged. "As long as you stop trying to find the artefacts yourself, you should be fine with proper security."

Adora shook her head. "Feuding amongst us won't help anyone. We need to secure the Naquadah before another catastrophe happens." She glanced at the television screen again even though they were reaching another military camp. "And this needs to be stopped. We aren't here to hurt anyone - we aren't hurting anyone. We just want to help you."

"Whether you wanted it or not, your arrival did result in a lot of my people getting hurt!" Salah spat.

Adora flinched, and Catra clenched her teeth. How dare this idiot do this to Adora! "Your people got hurt because of your own damn fault!" she spat. "If you hadn't tried to secure the Naquadah for yourself, none of this would have happened!"

"There were riots before all this!" Salah retorted. "People got hurt then - lots of them!"

"That's not on us either!" Catra snarled. "It's not our fault that you people freak out at meeting aliens!" It wasn't as if they were very different from Etherians, anyway.

"Or cannot stand people who love the same sex," Glimmer added with a scowl.

Salah opened his mouth with a gasp but closed it again without saying anything - even though it looked as if it was killing him to keep his mouth shut.

Catra bared her teeth in a sneer in return.

"So… we've landed," Bow said into the sudden silence. "Let's go and…" He looked at the main screen, which showed a group of soldiers walking towards them. "...meet the locals?"

Salah nodded, still clenching his teeth - Catra thought she could hear the noise they made - and then turned to leave the bridge, followed by the grimacing aide.

They stepped down the ramp just as the dozen soldiers led by another colonel arrived. Salah and the other colonel exchanged salutes, then talked to each other in their own language.

Catra glanced at Daniel and O'Neill. Both didn't seem to be concerned, so the two Egyptians probably weren't saying anything worrisome.

"This is Colonel Khaled," Salah finally introduced the man. "His men have secured the valley but haven't started excavating any site yet."

"We don't have their precise locations," Khaled admitted with a grin. "And I didn't want to have my men dig holes at random." Then he grew serious. "Given the events at the other site…"

Glimmer nodded. "This won't happen here. We won't let it happen."

And they had the exact locations thanks to Entrapta and Carter's scanner, Catra knew. This should be a breeze.

*****

Valley of the Kings, Egypt, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill jumped off the short ledge, landing on the sandy ground below without the slightest hint of pain. He really needed to talk to Adora about this - as much as he liked his body working as if he were twenty again, it was the result of magic. Magic he knew nothing about. If there were side-effects, or if this would suddenly revert back, he needed to know that.

He shook his head - he had to focus on the task at hand. Namely, the Goa'uld artefacts hidden under the sand and rock here.

"You're impatient, Jack," Daniel commented as he caught up - the others had taken a small path leading down the slope.

Jack glanced at his team. Daniel seemed honestly curious, but Carter's lips were doing that twisty thing they usually did when she was pondering something, and Teal'c… it seemed his right eyebrow had twitched about a tenth of an inch. "Just taking the direct way down," Jack said.

"We don't want to stay here forever, after all."

"Right!"

He looked up at the interruption and saw that Catra was already jumping down from the top of the slope - that was almost twenty feet. His eyes widened for a moment as the catwoman landed on all fours, then straightened as if that was just a particularly tall step. But he nodded as if he had expected that. "See?" He looked at Daniel. "That's impatient!"

Catra laughed. "I'm practical."

"You're a show-off!" Adora yelled.

The rest of the Etherians arrived in a less showy manner - though Jack had no doubt that Adora at least could've just jumped down as well. Hell, the woman could probably drop from orbit without feeling it! He blinked, then suppressed the urge to ask Carter whether that would actually be possible - she would probably try

to work it out. He cleared his throat. "Anyway, now that everyone's here…"

"The Egyptians are still on the way," Catra interrupted him.

He rolled his eyes. "Anyway, now that that everyone who actually matters is here, where's the Naquadah thingie?"

Entrapta pointed to the side with a tendril of her hair. "About… twenty metres that way!"

"Right!" Jack saw that Salah and Khaled and about a dozen soldiers were just joining them. "There you are. We're about to begin the excavation."

"Ah." Khaled nodded, then looked around. "Are you planning to use explosives?"

The man looked rather queasy at the thought, not that Jack could blame him.

"No, we're going to use a shovel," Catra said, grinning widely. "And by 'we', I mean 'Adora." Adora frowned at her friend, which didn't impress Catra at all, from what Jack could tell. "Atta, girl!"

With a sigh, Adora walked over to the spot Entrapta had indicated - and which Carter had confirmed, Jack checked with a glance - and raised her hand. A moment later, the by now familiar giant shovel appeared.

The soldiers started muttering at the sight, but Khaled seemed to take it in stride. Salah, of course, had seen it before and puffed his chest out a little.

Well, whatever let the guy save some face - the orders had been to play nice with the locals.

Grunting, Adora started digging, and Jack wandered over to check the perimeter. They were supposed to be far away from any mob, but he didn't exactly trust the soldiers guarding the site - it only

took one fanatic to sabotage everything if they got the opportunity.

Well, between Jack, Teal'c and Catra - he hadn't missed how she tended to lounge just where she had a good view of most of the soldiers - any saboteur would find their mission quite difficult.

*****

It didn't take Adora long to reach worked stone - the roof of a tomb, according to Daniel. Jack refrained from making a Tomb Raider joke. Mostly so he wouldn't have to explain why he knew the game - he had a reputation to defend, after all.

A few minutes later, they were staring at the sealed door. And Daniel was almost salivating. "This is… an untouched tomb!"

"Yes," Jack said, nodding. "Unless thieves got in and were polite enough to close the door behind them."

"Jack!" Daniel pouted. "Don't joke about this! Besides, the fact that there's Naquadah behind this door is a very strong clue that it is untouched - grave robbers wouldn't have left any item made of Naquadah behind!"

"In other words, we get to rob the grave!" Catra said, grinning widely.

Daniel turned his frown on her. "We're here to secure the Naquadah artefacts, not to rob a grave! We need to be extra careful so we don't destroy priceless historical artefacts!"

"No acting like Indiana Jones, got it," Jack said. "But we need to get through the door."

"That would be a lot easier if we had already activated Earth's magic," Glimmer said. "I could just teleport into the tomb."

"Or into a trap," Entrapta said. "Like in my castle, remember?"

“Don’t trigger any trap!” Salah blurted out.

“We won’t,” Entrapta told him. “We’re going to drill a hole and then check carefully for any traps.” Just as the man - and Khaled next to him - started to relax, she added: “The odds of drilling into a trap are very, very low.”

“And we’re not going to drill through without checking ahead with our scanner,” Carter quickly added.

That didn’t seem to do much to calm the two officers down.

Jack snorted. Well, that was Entrapta for you.

He quickly grew serious, though - he hadn’t missed that Glimmer was talking as if activating Earth’s magic was just a foregone conclusion. He could only hope the Egyptians had missed that.

*****

“Alright… penetrating the chamber now!” Entrapta announced.

Adora nodded. Finally! This had taken them long enough. She knew that they had to be cautious, but… Adora had trouble waiting and doing nothing while others worked hard. Unlike Catra, she added in her head while she looked at her lover sprawled over a larger rock, apparently enjoying the sun.

Though in this case, Catra wasn’t as calm and bored as she appeared - Adora could see her friend’s tail twitch.

“So, now we’ll find out if there’s a spoilsport device,” Jack commented. “Anyone taking bets?”

“Jack!”

“You are? Great. Five bucks on ‘we’re not going to get blown up’!”

Adora couldn’t help but giggle at Daniel’s expression, and she wasn’t the only one. But the Egyptians didn’t seem to think this

was funny. Perhaps it was something cultural.

“And we’re through!” Entrapta beamed at them. “Without blowing up! Now, let’s see what’s hidden here!”

And Jack was serious again, waking over to Sam and Entrapta, who had been joined by Daniel. “What do you see?”

“It looks like the expected interior of an Egyptian tomb of this era,” Daniel said. “The sarcophagus, the different vessels for the organs extracted during the mummification process and the burial objects.”

“The treasure, you mean.” Jack chuckled.

“Scanners show no active power sources, Sir,” Carter said.

“Batteries died?” Jack asked.

“No. But there’s no power being consumed right now.”

“Ah, good. We wouldn’t want to recover expensive paperweights.” He chuckled.

“So, this is safe?” Khaled asked.

“Define safe?” Entrapta turned to look at the man. “I mean, we didn’t detect a bomb - and my analyser shows no chemical explosive compound, either - but we haven’t checked for biological agents yet. With regards to chemical weapons, it should be safe since we didn’t detect anything particularly complex, so…”

“Biological weapons?” Colonel Salah’s voice sounded higher than before.

“One of the theories about the ‘curses’ placed on some tombs was that the Egyptians hid some toxic mushrooms or similar organisms in the tomb so any grave robbers would get sick and die,” Daniel explained. “It hasn’t been verified so far, though.”

Which was a very good thing, even though Adora was pretty sure she could heal such a poison. To do all that, just to protect a grave… She shook her head. "So, once it is safe, want me to break down the door?"

Daniel gasped. "But that would destroy it!"

"I think we can use a bot to open it - we need to repair the mechanism that sealed it, then you should be able to open it," Entrapta replied.

"Or we can cut the door out and have it taken away whole," Sam suggested.

"I guess that would be faster," Entrapta admitted. "But it would destroy this fascinating mechanism."

"Let's go with 'faster' - we're kind of on the clock here. A doomsday clock," Jack said.

Most seemed to agree, and Entrapta pouted a little but then started on the cutting process with Sam.

Adora walked over to Catra. "Relax," she whispered as she reached her friend. "It should be safe now."

"I'm not concerned about the tomb," Catra replied. "I'm keeping an eye on the soldiers."

"Oh." Adora blinked.

"It would only take one traitor amongst them to wreck this mission," Catra went on.

Adora bit her lower lip to avoid mentioning Double-Trouble. That was still a sore spot for her lover - and probably the reason why she was so suspicious of everyone except for Adora and her friends. Well, that and Horde Prime's mind-control chips. "Ah," she said instead, looking up at the people guarding the site.

Fortunately, Entrapta called for her before the silence became awkward.

“I’ll keep an eye out. Go use your muscles!” Catra grinned at her.

Adora smiled back, then bent down, placing a quick kiss on Catra’s lips. “Thanks.”

“Someone has to keep you guys alive,” Catra mumbled when Adora withdrew - but she was blushing.

And then Adora was grunting as she pulled the stone door away. It wasn’t particularly heavy, but getting a grip was difficult. She would’ve liked to cut some handholds into the stone, but that would probably upset Daniel.

She almost dropped the thing - and wouldn’t that have been embarrassing! - but finally managed to lean it against the wall next to the door. Whew!

Daniel was already trying to move past her, but Jack held him back. “Let’s check for booby traps first.”

“We already did, Jack!”

“I mean, let someone else enter,” Jack explained. “Just in case.”

And that meant Adora. She stepped into the grave, wrinkling her nose at the stale and dusty air, and looked around. It seemed safe. “Looks safe,” she said. “At least this room.”

“‘This room’?” Daniel asked. “Jack!”

“I said wait, Daniel!”

“Well, there’s a door to another room, I think,” Adora replied, walking past the stone casket. It looked like a door, at least.

“Scanners do show a second room, now that the seal has been breached,” Sam reported.

“Oh! Let’s open the door!” Entrapta suggested.

“Let’s drill through it first,” Jack told her. “Nice and slow.”

Adora smiled when she heard Entrapta sigh. Her friend was still very impatient when she was intrigued.

And here came Daniel. “That’s a fake door, carved into the wall after building it. But if there is a room behind it…” He looked at the symbols on the door. “‘Chariot of the Sky’?” He gasped. “This must be a ship!”

*****

The Naquadah Crisis Part 4

Valley of the Kings, Egypt, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Chariot of the sky - this has to be a ship!" Daniel repeated himself.

Samantha Carter frowned. "The room can't be large enough for an Al'kesh. Maybe a Death Glider," she added when she saw her friend frown.

"Why would anyone bury a spaceship?" Adora asked.

"Many ancient cultures believed that the dead would be able to use the items that were buried with them in the afterlife," Daniel explained. "Warriors were often buried with weapons. Sometimes, this extended to their horses and dogs. Even people - usually slaves - were sometimes killed and buried with high-ranking persons, to serve them even after death."

"That's sick!" Glimmer blurted out.

"Well, it wasn't common," Daniel retorted.

"But… perfectly fine tools, weapons and jewellery?" Catra shook her head. "What a waste!"

Sam had to agree with that. Even though such finds were very helpful for archaeologists.

"That's why substitutes were also common - clay soldiers, non-functional chariots…" Daniel blinked. "This could be the case here as well."

"A mock-up of a spaceship?" The Colonel raised his eyebrows.

"It would certainly fit Egyptian culture. Although…" Daniel bent down to check the sarcophagus. "'Favoured of Ra'..."

“So, what? Is there a Jaffa in that tomb?” The Colonel asked.

“The Goa’uld believed in clay soldiers as grave gifts?” Glimmer asked.

“They wouldn’t - but their soldiers and slaves did. At least, they did so on Abydos.” Daniel frowned, as usual, when talking about the planet of his wife. “Although this could be a tomb dating to the time after Ra was driven off Earth. The inscriptions only talk about mighty victories, without naming anything we could use to determine the time period or location.”

“But would they mention a ‘sky chariot’ as a grave gift?” Sam asked. That seemed a bit… Odd.

“If the man buried here was a great warrior, he could have passed into myth, and so the grave inscriptions would reflect that. Especially if the grave was built several years after his death.”

“Or her death,” Adora said.

“Ah… The iconography used here, and the culture of Ancient Egypt, makes it very unlikely that this would be a woman’s grave,” Daniel said. “Ancient Egypt was a patriarchal culture. Women wouldn’t have been praised as great warriors.”

Sam pressed her lips together. On Etheria, this kind of sexism didn’t exist. She wasn’t about to immigrate, but it was nice to know that not every world had copied Earth’s cultures.

“Wasn’t their culture installed by the Goa’uld?” Bow asked with a frown.

“We don’t actually know if the Goa’uld decided to take over an existing culture by impersonating their gods, or if they installed the culture posing as gods,” Daniel explained.

“Well, how about we check?” the Colonel suggested. “I mean the ship. We can rob the grave afterwards.”

“Colonel O’Neill!” Salah gasped.

“I was joking,” the Colonel told him. “But we will have to check the sarcophagus as well for any Naquadah items.” He grinned. “So, technically, we will be grave robbers.”

Catra snorted, but the others weren’t amused, Sam could tell. Shaking her head, she turned back to examining the wall with Entrapta.

Her research partner - she wouldn’t call them ‘science buddies’, especially not since that was Entrapta’s term for Hordak - hadn’t paid much attention to the discussion about Egyptian beliefs. She was waving her multi-purpose tool around and noting down numbers.

“Are you scanning the wall’s width?” Sam asked.

“Yes. But it’s uniform. There’s no door that was bricked up or a weaker portion - the wall was built in one piece.” Entrapta frowned. “No interesting mechanism to open it.”

“Sometimes, that simplifies things,” Sam said.

“Simple is boring.”

But boring was often quite nice. You couldn’t really do proper research if you constantly had to fight for your life. “If we don’t want to risk explosives, we could dig through the wall with a jackhammer,” Sam suggested.

“A jackhammer?” Entrapta turned to look at the Colonel.

“It’s the name for a powered tool that combines a hammer with a chisel,” Sam explained with a smile. “It has nothing to do with the Colonel.”

“Ah.” Entrapta nodded. “But that would take time. We could have Adora slice through the wall.”

“Yeah, that would be best,” Catra cut in - the woman had literally ears like a cat, Sam reminded herself. “Quick and dirty.”

“Hey!”

Sam shook her head with a wry smile. But the Etherians were correct - Adora’s sword would make short work of the wall. “We should drill through first to check for traps,” she cautioned.

“Yes!”

Carefully drilling through solid stone took some time, but they were now quite used to it. After a few minutes, they were through - and had avoided triggering an explosion. She sighed softly with relief. They had scanned for any trigger or suspicious device and hadn’t found anything, but Sam knew that there was always the possibility that they had missed something - no one and no technology was perfect, and Sam was pretty sure that magic wasn’t perfect either.

“We’re through!” Entrapta announced as Sam picked up a camera to push through the hole.

It took a bit of finagling, but Sam was an old hand at that. The thin cone of the lamp attached to the camera cut through the darkness on the other side of the wall, and Sam drew a sharp breath. That form…

“It’s a Death Glider!” Daniel whispered. “And it’s not a wooden or clay copy!”

It wasn’t - but, as Sam realised quickly as she let the flashlight pane over the craft, it wasn’t a working Death Glider. There were obvious signs of damage. And of wear and tear far beyond the usual.

“They took a wreck and buried it with him!” Daniel exclaimed.

“What a waste,” the Colonel commented.

Sam glanced at Daniel and shook her head before her friend could try to correct the Colonel.

“A spaceship?” Colonel Salah asked. Sam saw his eyes widen.

“A wreck,” the Colonel corrected him. “Which we will be taking with us.”

The Egyptian stared at him.

“That’s what the United Nations Security Council decided,” Daniel reminded Salah. “All alien technology found on Earth is to be recovered and put under the control of the United Nations.”

“Egypt is a member of the United Nations,” Salah objected. “We can keep it safe for the Security Council’s final decision.”

“Yeah… I don’t think so,” the Colonel said, shaking his head. “You don’t have a good record when it comes to keeping alien technology safe, sorry.”

Sam suppressed a sigh at the Colonel’s very much not apologetic grin. The Colonel was a great officer - brave, smart, caring - but he wasn’t a diplomat. Hordak nodding in obvious agreement wasn’t helping any, either.

*****

“You seriously think we’ll leave the ship here? After your capital almost blew up?” Catra shook her head. She’d seen less ridiculous proposals by Kyle during cadet training.

Khaled cringed at the reminder, but Salah frowned. “That was sabotage.”

“Sabotage you should’ve prevented,” Catra retorted. “I would say that disproves your claim that you can keep the ship safe.”

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “We can’t risk another such explosion.”

“We don’t know what or who caused the explosion,” Bow added. “And so it seems best to move the ship to a safer place.”

Like, anywhere but Egypt, Catra thought.

“Moving it may set off a bomb,” Khaled pointed out.

“Carter is the best expert for alien technology on Earth,” O’Neill said.

Catra was tempted to argue that Entrapta was technically on Earth as well but held her tongue. The faster they got this settled, the faster they could leave this place. Hordak must share her thoughts since he didn’t comment either.

“So, yeah, we’ll be taking the ship with us,” O’Neill repeated himself. “Before someone blows it up for whatever reason.”

“And how will you move it?” Salah asked with a sneer. “You need our cranes and heavy machinery for that!”

“Nope!” O’Neill grinned again. “We’ve got all the heavy lifting we need here.” He pointed at Adora, who nodded, then blinked.

“Hey!”

Catra giggled at her lover’s expression. And at the blinking, shocked faces of the Egyptians.

They really had no idea about Adora’s power.

“So, let’s cut our way in,” O’Neill said.

“Wait! Let’s take a few more pictures. Just for safety’s sake!” Daniel stepped forward and started taking pictures of the wall with his camera.

“Actually, Sir, if we have to move the craft anyway, we might as well go in through the roof,” Carter suggested.

“After we checked for boobytraps there,” O’Neill replied. “And we best do that from the inside.”

“So, let’s cut the door open!” Entrapta hefted a large, vaguely weapon-like tool. One of her cutting lasers, Catra realised. “We’ll make a real door out of the fake door! In fact, if we had heavy-duty hinges, we could make a door we can open and close.”

“Let’s focus on securing the ship,” Carter said. Before Entrapta started turning the tomb into a working hangar.

Cutting along the lines of the fake door would take a while, Catra knew. “I’m going to get some fresh air,” she announced, wrinkling her nose.”And I don’t want to get dust on my fur.”

Glimmer snorted in return, and Adora nodded after a moment, but the Egyptians and Daniel were probably fooled.

Outside, she spotted a dozen guards - she couldn’t tell if they were the same who had been with Khaled when Darla had landed - surrounding the site. No heavy weapons, though. No tanks, no APCs. And about half of the soldiers were staring at her instead of keeping an eye out for threats.

Then again, she thought, I am one of the bigger threats here, so I guess I can’t blame them for that.

She stretched, just to make it believable, then started a light jog up the slope, towards Darla. A soldier on top of the slope moved as if he wanted to block her way, but another held him back. Grinning, she waved at them and then sped up, racing towards Darla. She didn’t go on all four, though - it was always better to keep some ace up your sleeve, as Daniel had explained the saying.

Which was another reason for her quick trip back to Darla. She entered the ship - Darla extended the ramp as she approached - and went to the weapons locker. It contained both Shock rods and staves, some of them Horde issue and some that were probably

spares in case Glimmer broke her own staff over the head of someone who annoyed her too much.

Chuckling at the idea, she grabbed a Horde-style staff and left the ship again.

"Ah, you remembered that you should never enter a dungeon without your trusty ten-foot pole?" O'Neill asked when Catra rejoined them. Judging by his grin, that was a joke she wasn't supposed to get.

"Jack!" Daniel shook his head. "He's referring to Dungeons and Dragons where the players can use poles to check for traps."

"Your miniature game!" Bow beamed. "We really should play a game together!"

Catra frowned, and Adora and Glimmer groaned. Bow was a little too enthusiastic about this. But she wouldn't shoot him down - she'd leave that to Glimmer.

So she grinned and twirled her staff in her hand. "I just wanted a few more options if we're facing something that I don't want to get too close to."

Fortunately, Entrapta announced that they were through the door, and people got serious again. Catra really didn't want to talk about miniatures.

*****

Jack O'Neill was really glad for Carter and Entrapta's timing. The last thing he wanted to do in the middle of an ancient tomb was talk about Dungeons and Dragons. Especially with an enthusiastic fan - Jack really should have known better than to crack a D&D joke. Sometimes, he played himself.

But now he got to watch Adora show off again as she grabbed the cut-out 'door' and pulled, slowly dragging the massive slab of stone out of the wall. It wasn't the first time he saw it - she had

done the same to the door into this chamber - but it was still a sight to see. Like a comic book hero come alive.

He blinked and then shook his head to push the picture of Adora in a Supergirl outfit away. Besides, the woman couldn't fly, and he preferred Batman, anyway. You didn't need superpowers to defeat an enemy; just skill and smarts and some luck. Like… No, not going there.

He felt a slight draft of air as the door was pushed to the side - without breaking apart, as he had half-expected - and they could enter the second chamber, then held back Daniel; Carter was too sensible to rush in. "Let the magical girl enter first, Daniel," he told his friend. "She can take a hit from a tank gun - you can't."

That made Catra snort and the two Egyptians goggle at them. Probably revising their estimates of the aliens? That would be a good thing. The sooner the rest of Earth realised just how powerful the Etherians were - and how dangerous the Goa'uld were - the better. Jack was heartily sick of all the posturing and denial.

Why couldn't the politicians not simply trust them? Just because they had kept the Stargate a secret for so long? He snorted and pushed the thought away; he was here for a mission, not to think about politics.

Adora was already entering the room with the wrecked Death Glider, so Jack followed her, ignoring the way Carter frowned at him. He led from the front, damn it, and he was responsible for his team!

The room wasn't much larger than the ship - probably literally built around it before the sand buried it or something. No sign of any traps, but that didn't mean anything.

"I don't detect any Naquadah outside the ship," Entrapta said behind him - he could see the tips of her hair tendrils move just inside his field of vision.

“No sign of any power in use,” Carter added. “Not in the wreck or the walls.”

Well, that made things look a little safer.

Jack took a step to the side as the two women passed him and started to examine the ship, followed by Bow and Daniel. Hordak, though, stayed back, watching the Egyptians. And the entrance to the tomb. Well, Jack couldn’t blame him for that.

“This looks like battle damage. Staff weapons, probably,” Entrapta said.

“Yes. There aren’t any signs of any attempt to repair it. Maybe it was damaged and abandoned during the rebellion?” Carter speculated.

“They recovered it to entomb it here, though,” Daniel objected. “So, either this happened after the rebellion - and why would the victorious rebels honour a follower of Ra like this? - or Ra’s forces recovered the ship during the rebellion but then spent the time to entomb it. Which also seems unlikely. No, based on the information so far, I think this tomb predates the rebellion!”

“But would the head snake really sacrifice a ship like that?” Jack asked. Ra hadn’t struck him as a guy who cared about honouring his followers like that.

“If it was irreparable, he might have felt the gesture worth it - such an honour would likely have helped tie his guards to him,” Daniel said. “Oh! If this happened during Ra’s reign on Earth, then this might be a Jaffa’s grave! On Earth!”

Jack glanced at Teal’c, who was looking at the ship, then back at the sarcophagus. His friend was hard to read normally, and right now, Jack couldn’t tell what he was thinking at all. Teal’c’s expression looked like stone.

He cleared his throat. “So, is it repairable?”

“Anything is technically repairable as long as you are willing to spend the resources,” Entrapta said. “So, even if the engine and electronics are gone, we could replace them, I think.”

“But it would probably not be cost-effective,” Carter objected. “If we are basically rebuilding a ship, we might as well build a model more suited to our purposes.”

Jack nodded and suppressed the urge to make a Star Wars or Battlestar Galactica joke. Even though flying an X-Wing or a Viper would be a dream come true. But Daniel would never let him hear the end of it. And Carter would be worse - she might even design such a ship… “So, how damaged is it?” he asked.

“Well…” Entrapta cocked her head to the side, visor sliding down over her face.

“The engine is damaged, but the damage doesn’t seem too extensive,” Carter said.

“Yes. But the control system… all the crystals have been removed. Or destroyed. The ship is basically braindead,” Entrapta added. “Can you lift it a little, Adora?”

“Sure!”

“I don’t think the ship had much of a brain.” Bow pointed at a wrecked part. “That doesn’t seem to be able to house a crystal big enough to grant a personality.”

“Right. Poor thing.” Entrapta sighed. “We’ll do better when we rebuild it! And we need to name it!” She tilted her head to the other side. “I’m thinking… Clarice!”

“Clarice?” Bow asked.

“She looks like a Clarice. And sad.”

Jack wasn’t going to ask about that. Not at all. But he would have to impress upon Hammond that Entrapta wasn’t allowed to name

any ship Earth might be building with her help. Serving on a battleship named 'Hannah' or 'Sophie' would be simply embarrassing. Ah, well, time to…

"Oops."

He froze. That wasn't something he wanted to hear from anyone, least of all Entrapta.

*****

"'Oops'?" Adora froze in the middle of lifting the left wing of the ship. If Entrapta said 'Oops', that often meant 'Run!'.

"Moving the ship just started something that moves - it's not magic or electricity-based, or we would have detected it," Entrapta explained. "Don't move while we analyse it!"

"Ok…" Adora clenched her teeth. The ship - a Death Glider - wasn't particularly heavy - not nearly as heavy as a tank, and she could throw those - but she didn't have the best leverage, and the metal felt a little… not quite slippery, but fragile. If she gripped it too hard, it might bend. Or break.

And then Entrapta crawled under the ship, her hair fanning out. "Oh… it's a purely mechanical mechanism! Fascinating!"

"Yeah, fascinating. And what does it do?" Jack asked.

"We don't know yet, Sir," Sam replied - she was crouching down to take a look at the underside of the ship as well. "But it's a clockwork mechanism."

"And it is still working after all those years?" Daniel, like Entrapta, sounded more intrigued than afraid. "That's… actually a point against my theory that this tomb dates back to the time of Ra's reign on Earth."

"Don't sound so disappointed," Jack told him. "Maybe you catch a break, and we all get blown up before anyone can reveal your

mistake."

"Jack!"

Adora heard Catra snort.

"It looks like the mechanism is connected to a small container made out of Naquadah," Sam said.

"And the mechanism is made out of Naquadah," Entrapta added.

"And what's in the container?" Catra asked.

"We can't tell yet," Sam replied. "The container is shielding the contents."

"We should be able to calibrate the scanner to get around that," Entrapta said. "I guess we don't want to open it before we know what's in it."

"Yeah, I don't think we want to risk releasing whatever the Goa'uld might have put into a Pandora's Box."

"What's a Pandora's Box?" Adora asked.

"It's a myth - a container that held all the evils of the world, which were released because the holder, Pandora, got curious," Daniel explained. "This could be a trap to deal with grave robbers."

"But it's not open yet?" Glimmer asked.

"Not as far as we can tell," Bow replied from under the wing - Adora could only see his legs.

"If it's a trap, why didn't it trigger already?" Glimmer knelt down next to Bow.

"It must have some leeway or delay - a security margin - so it's not triggered by an Earthquake," Daniel speculated.

“Yes. The clockwork mechanism might be a way to introduce a delay,” Sam agreed. “But it’s still working, if slowly.”

“So we’ve got a time bomb,” Jack said. “Can you defuse it?”

“We should be able to, Sir. But you might want to retreat to a safe distance,” Sam told him.

“If it’s a nuclear or Naquadah-enhanced bomb, there might be no safe distance,” Daniel pointed out.

And someone had to hold up the ship so they could work, Adora knew.

“Though if there’s a delay, then there’s also a safety,” Entrapta said.

“Yes,” Sam agreed. “If removing the weight of the ship triggers the mechanism, replacing it should stop it - so an Earthquake shaking the ship would not trigger it after the ship comes to a rest again.”

“Yes. So… let’s see which of the studs sticking up would do that.” Entrapta wriggled fully under the ship.

“Or I could just put the ship down,” Adora suggested.

“But then we couldn’t get at the mechanism or get the ship out!” Entrapta retorted from below. “Don’t worry - it’s a simple mechanism once you see it.”

“And it’s still running?” Catra asked.

“Yes.”

That wasn’t reassuring. Not to Adora. But Sam, Bow and Entrapta were all underneath the ship now. Even Hordak had stopped standing guard and was using a scanner to analyse the ship.

“This looks good,” Entrapta said.

“But it’s not connected to the mechanism according to the scanner,” Bow objected.

“Right. It might be a decoy then. Too good to be true.”

“How about this?” Sam asked.

“Oh, yes. That… see the strut there? And the lever?”

“Yes.”

“Now, how do we depress it enough to trigger the failsafe?”

Adora drew a sharp breath. The failsafe? Like back in the Heart of Etheria? No. This wasn’t a magical superweapon about to destroy the world and the local sector. This was just a bomb or something.

But it would kill all her friends anyway if it went off.

“I’m pushing it down… Or not,” Bow said. “It seems stuck.”

“No, I think the mechanism just needs more power to trigger.”

More power? But Adora had to keep holding the ship.

“We need leverage. Catra! Your staff!”

And now Catra crawled under the wing as well!

“Put it here… yes… now we can… Teal’C? If you could help push the staff down?”

“I shall try.” He started to push the end of the staff down, bracing himself against the wing Adora was holding.

“Something went click,” Catra said.

“That’s the failsafe. Now we need to weld or solder the clockworks together to keep it stuck,” Sam said.

“Aw. That’ll ruin it. And after thousands of years of working perfectly.”

Adora gritted her teeth. It wasn’t Entrapta’s fault that she was like that. But sometimes, it was really annoying.

At least they had defused whatever trap this was.

*****

“Do we really have to destroy the mechanism?” Entrapta asked.

Samantha Carter suppressed a sigh. While she could understand Entrapta’s stance towards destroying such an old piece of technology - she wasn’t fond of that herself - she would rather not take any risk when it came to traps laid by - possibly - Goa’uld. Not after seeing the crater near Cairo.

“We could block it.” Bow, obviously, was a bit more prone to taking risks.

“That would likely damage it as well, at least if we wanted to ensure that the mechanism doesn’t work any more,” Sam pointed out.

“Well… what would be easier to repair?” Bow asked.

“Using something to block the clockworks,” Entrapta said. “The clockworks can’t exert too much force, but we should probably use Naquadah alloys to be sure it won’t just be crushed and spat out.”

“Yes!” Bow nodded, almost hitting his head on the wing above him.

“Or we can destroy the shaft that links the mechanism to the container,” Hordak suggested. “We only have to go through the stone here.” He pointed at a slab of stone in the ground.

“Technically, that would destroy the mechanism as well, since that’s part of it,” Bow pointed out.

“Are you arguing whether or not you should damage a trap that might kill us all if it triggered?” the Colonel sounded incredulous.

Sam felt herself blush and was glad she was currently hidden from sight by the craft above her.

“Jack! This is a historical artefact that might give us crucial clues about the origin of this tomb!” Daniel, predictably, protested.

“I vote for ‘destroy it to be sure’,” Catra cut in.

“Can we move the ship now?” Adora asked.

“Oh, sorry - I forgot about that,” Entrapta replied. “Yes, you can move it to the side.”

Adora grunted, and then the entire ship tilted forward, sliding a little over the floor before the nose was stopped by the wall. Then the woman turned it to the side and put it down. “I need some better grip to carry it out.”

“We can get some cables to make a harness,” Catra suggested.

“Can we stop the bomb or whatever it is, first?” the Colonel asked. “Like, priorities, people!”

“Alright… let’s uncover the mechanism first,” Bow said.

That didn’t take them long.

“Oh! It’s a beautiful piece of craftsmanship!”

“It reminds me a little of the Antikythera mechanism,” Daniel commented. “Although that is thousands of years younger.”

“And the underlying mechanics would demand a similar construction,” Sam pointed out. “This does not have to mean anything.”

“But it would explain how such a mechanism appeared almost out of the blue,” Daniel insisted.

The Colonel coughed behind them.

“Well, let’s cut the shaft - that’s easier to repair than the clockworks,” Bow repeated his idea.

Cutting Naquadah alloys was always a bit of an effort, complicated by having to reach down alongside the clockworks, but Adora transformed her sword into something like a slim sabre, and not even Naquadah could offer much resistance to a magical blade. Or a blade made of magic - Sam made a mental note to ask the princess if she could analyse it.

“Yes!” Entrapta’s hair wriggled into the opening and lifted the mechanism out.

“Now we need to secure the container with the payload,” Sam reminded the others.

“And find out what would have happened if we hadn’t stopped the mechanism, yes.” Entrapta nodded in agreement.

With a bit more help from Adora, who got teased by Catra about being a nice tool, and by the Colonel for having a ‘magical swiss army sword’, the container was exposed. It was made from Naquadah as well, and…

“This is sealed very tightly,” Sam commented. “Airtight according to the scan.” And, in her experience, people didn’t do that unless they needed such a seal.

“Yes. Whatever is inside must not have been allowed to get out.”

“How reassuring,” the Colonel commented.

“Probably a biological or chemical weapon, based upon your comment earlier,” Hordak said, nodding at Daniel.

Who paled a little. “The curse… if this contains poison…”

“...then we might not be dealing with some poisonous spores, but an actual Goa’uld bioweapon,” Sam finished the thought for her friend.

“A bioweapon?” Salah blurted out - Sam had almost forgotten that the Egyptians were there. Sloppy, she berated herself.

“That would be the worst case,” she told the officer. “It could also be a chemical weapon. Or merely a poisonous substance or a pathogen available to ancient Egypt.”

“But since that container was made out of Naquadah alloy, we shouldn’t assume it’s something harmless,” Daniel added.

“Well, let’s calibrate the scanner and see if we can find out what it is without opening it!” Entrapta said.

That took a few minutes, and the scan itself took a bit of time as well, but the results…

“There’s definitely something in there,” Bow said.

“And it’s under slight pressure. If the lid opens, it would quickly escape into the air,” Samanta said. Ideal for a trap using poison gas. Or a biological weapon.

“But you can’t tell what it is?” The Colonel asked,

“No, sorry - we need to take a sample for that,” Entrapta told him.

“No! The risk is too great!” Salah protested.

“Not here,” Entrapta told him. “We’ll probably do it in orbit in a safe lab.”

Sam suppressed the slight jealousy she felt at hearing that. An orbital lab would allow so many research projects…

*****

“Careful, Emily - don’t break the seals!”

“Yeah, be very careful,” Catra muttered under her breath as Entrapta pep talked the bot carrying the container. “Or at least if you do, don’t break your hull.” The sealed hull of the bot should contain any poison or pathogen.

“Catra! Align the doors!” Adora yelled from below.

Right. Catra sighed and squinted down the ramp. “A little to the left, Bow,” she spoke into the commlink. “The other left,” she added when the ship drifted to the right. “OK, a bit more… stop!” She checked again, then yelled. “It’s alright, you can lift!”

Down below in the tomb - now with the roof removed - Adora pulled on the makeshift pulley, braced against the floor, and the Death Glider - and wasn’t that an ominous name for a ship? - started to rise. A minute later, it was hanging in front of the lowered ramp of Darla, and Catra quickly attached a few more ropes to pull it inside. Well, far enough so it would rest on the ramp - Adora could do the rest once she climbed out of the tomb.

“Well, I can’t fault the efficiency of using brute force.” O’Neill thought he was funny.

Catra snorted. “It’s not exactly brute force - Adora’s not simply carrying the thing inside.” That would have been Plan B.

“It’s pure muscle power. Brute force,” the man insisted.

“Whatever,” Catra said, stretching. “It works.”

“Can’t argue with that,” he agreed. “And it impressed the local yokels.”

“Aren’t you supposed to be diplomatic?” She raised her eyebrows at him.

“What? They can’t hear me - they’re both still in the tomb, arguing with Daniel about the sarcophagus.” O’Neill chuckled.

“They don’t know how stubborn Daniel can be, for all his niceness. Although if you could have claimed that there was some Naquadah in the sarcophagus, we wouldn’t have to argue about taking the thing with us,” he added with a nod at Entrapta.

“I won’t lie about data!” Entrapta retorted with a frown. “How can we expect people to trust us if we lie to them?”

Well, as long as they didn’t realise that they were lied to, their trust wasn’t affected. But any lie tended to be revealed sooner or later.

“It would have been a white lie,” O’Neill insisted. “And we don’t know if the sarcophagus doesn’t contain something dangerous, so it wouldn’t have been a real lie.”

“But we didn’t detect anything dangerous!” she protested.

“Your scanner couldn’t identify the contents of this little surprise, could they?”

“I said so.”

“Let it go,” Catra told him, baring her teeth at him for a moment. Entrapta wasn’t one of his subordinates. And she didn’t deserve to be berated for being herself, instead of some… someone like that traitor Double-Trouble.

He met her eyes for a moment, then sighed. “Sorry. I’m just sick of all the talking when the end result is clear.”

She snorted again - she could understand the feeling.

“I thought the real problem started when you stop talking,” Entrapta commented.

Catra grimaced. That was… not wrong.

“Not always,” O’Neill said. “Sometimes, too much talking and not enough doing is the problem.”

“Sounds like that’s mostly an Earth problem,” Catra couldn’t resist saying.

He frowned at her. “I’m sure you had your pointless meetings as well.”

“Not too many when I was in charge of running things,” she retorted.

“Well, we did have a lot of talks in the Alliance,” Entrapta said. “But I wouldn’t call them pointless.”

“What are you doing?”

Catra turned. Adora was standing on the ramp, looking at them with narrowed eyes. She was a little dusty. Or was that sandy?

“We’re discussing whether too much talking or too little taking is the bigger problem,” Entrapta told her with a smile. “What do you think?”

“I think not enough thinking is the problem,” Adora shot back. “Now help me pull the ship fully into Darla.”

Well, if she asked like that… Catra grinned and went forward to help her lover.

It took them five minutes and two almost broken ropes, but they managed to help Adora move the Death Glider into the hold of the ship and secure it there with the magnetic clamps. Adora sighed. “Finally!” She wiped the back of her hand over her forehead as if she had sweated.

“And now we can go and pick up the sarcophagus. And by ‘we’, I mean ‘you’,” Catra told her.

Adora groaned again. “Why is it that I’m always doing the heavy lifting?”

"Because you're the logical choice for that," Entrapta told her with a smile. "None of us can lift as much as you can."

"I know that," Adora said.

"Oh. Why did you ask then?"

"It was a rhetorical question," Adora told her. "Let's go and grab the coffin."

Catra followed her down the ramp into the tomb. Her ears twitched as she heard Daniel's voice before she saw him: "...and I assure you, you will get the sarcophagus back should we determine that it's not of alien origin."

"That is not good enough. This belongs to Egypt - it's our history!" Salah argued.

"Not if it's of alien origin."

They entered the grave chamber. "He's still arguing," O'Neill muttered, and Catra couldn't tell if he meant Daniel or Salah.

Not that it mattered. Adora harrumphed and picked up the sarcophagus without a word, then turned and carried it out.

Catra flashed her fangs at the Egyptian. "Thank you for your cooperation!" she quoted one of the movies she had watched.

*****

Above the East Mediterranean Sea, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

...dozens, maybe hundreds, dead or wounded in the so-called 'crater riot' - it's hard to tell, with thousands being injured or killed in the blast that almost destroyed Cairo. The Egyptian authorities didn't answer questions at the press conference and merely released a statement that the threat to the country had been handled.

Jack O'Neill didn't wince when he watched the news on the bridge of Darla. He had expected that once he had seen the size of the riot - and that the people were attacking a line of soldiers, not cops prepared for riot control.

But the Etherians hadn't expected that. Well, they had seen the start, before the trapped tomb kind of took priority, but they seemed still shocked. Those on the bridge, at least - Entrapta and Bow were with Carter in the hold, analysing the Death Glider. And, hopefully, keeping Entrapta from tinkering with the Naquadah container before they were in a secure lab in orbit.

"This is…" Glimmer shook her head. "Why did they keep attacking? Why didn't they break after the warning shots?"

"Or after the first volleys from the soldiers?" Catra asked.

"They showed a much stronger morale than expected," Hordak commented. "I will have to revise my estimate of the quality of troops from Earth."

Well, some probably were just surprised. Just as Jack was surprised that Hordak wasn't with Entrapta in the hold.

"Hordak!" Glimmer snapped. "Those weren't soldiers - those were civilians!"

"Exactly." The alien nodded. "That means a trained soldier should be even fiercer." He cocked his head to the side. "Perhaps the sheer number of people on the planet shaped a culture that considered lives expendable in war?"

Jack clenched his teeth. This was…

"Well, in the past, similar sentiments were quite common in certain cultures, but as history proved, societies where soldiers were considered expendable tended to be less stable than those who cared for all their members," Daniel said. "And these days, most countries try to avoid taking casualties."

“Human wave attacks went out of style fifty years ago,” Jack quipped.

Hordak turned to face him. “That seems to contradict some of the movies we saw about the last protracted conflict your country was involved in.”

Jack sighed. “Those are movies, fiction, not historical documents.”

“Ah. Still, wouldn’t the existence of such fiction indicate a lingering tendency for such tactics?”

Jack looked at Daniel. Cultural clashes were his friend’s field. Jack was the expert for the other kind of clashes.

Daniel pushed his glasses up his nose and nodded. “It would generally indicate an attempt to portray the enemy as unsophisticated, uncaring and cruel towards their own people.”

“Ah. Propaganda.” Hordak nodded.

Daniel opened his mouth, blinked, then nodded as well. “Effectively, yes. It reinforces cultural stereotypes.”

Jack snorted - softly; the pictures of the carnage in Egypt still played on the screen. “That’s quite the condemnation of Hollywood.”

“The movie industry as a whole does tend to cater to the target audience’s cultural values,” Daniel replied.

“You must be a very violent society, then,” Glimmer commented. “Judging by your entertainment.”

Jack bit down on a flippant remark about not doing blood sports any more since the Romans Empire fell. “We also have lots of wholesome family entertainment,” he said instead. “And we have the Simpsons.”

"Which often feature violence in an exaggerated form used for comedic effect," Daniel cut in. Jack glared at him, but his friend shrugged. "It's true."

"Well, we saw some of those shows as well," Glimmer said. "They seemed rather… formulaic was the word, I believe."

"Yes. And they were also very 'conservative'," Catra added. Though she used the word as if it were an insult. Well, if they had seen some of the favourite TV shows of the conservatives, it probably was an insult for her.

"Oh, yes. Such shows tend to be rather conservative," Daniel agreed. "There are exceptions, but most reinforce current values, often by portraying an idealised family. Some scientists suggested using the portrayal of alternative lifestyles in daytime TV as an indicator to gauge how progressive a society is. This kind of approach does seem to be…"

Jack sighed with relief when Daniel's explanation was interrupted by an incoming call from Stargate Command. It was Hammond. "Colonel O'Neill. Queen Glimmer. Princess Adora. Dr Jackson. We've received your preliminary report."

"We haven't had the time to work on a more comprehensive report," Daniel said as if Hammond would expect a dissertation in a day.

"I'm aware of that. Good work." Hammond nodded.

Jack shrugged, "We just went in and got the stuff."

Hammond snorted. "I'm aware of the situation on the ground. Egypt already filed a protest with the Security Council, demanding access to the 'cultural relics taken from Egypt'."

"Well, some of the best experts on ancient Egypt are Egyptian historians and archaeologists," Daniel said. "They could help with analysing the recent find. Just cross-checking assumptions would facilitate the translations."

“I’m sure that will be taken into account, Dr Jackson,” Hammond replied. “Though recent events also have raised some security concerns.”

Daniel blinked, so Jack added: “They need to be vetted.”

“Oh.”

“But I am not calling because of that,” Hammond went on. “As of half an hour ago, Honduras formally requested assistance with recovering an alien artefact in their country.”

Jack blinked, then pressed his lips together. “Why do I have a bad feeling about this, Sir?”

“Because we’ve been monitoring their communications, and they lost contact with the soldiers sent to ‘secure’ the artefacts. After incoherent screaming about the ‘dead walking again’ according to our interpreters.”

Jack groaned. “Don’t tell me we’re dealing with zombies, Sir.” Couldn’t they catch a break for once?

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The Naquadah Crisis Part 5

Earth Orbit, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"And guard it well. Do not let anyone tamper with it." Adora tried to smile as she gave the order. Just so the clones wouldn't…

"We shall defend it with our lives! None shall even as much as gaze on it while one of us yet draws breath, Your Divine Highness!"

…do that. Overreact to every little request. She suppressed the urge to grimace. They didn't know any better. Not yet. "Very well. We will depart, but we - or some of us - will return to properly analyse the threat this container poses."

"As you command, Your Divine Highness!" every clone present chorused, saluting her.

Adora didn't sigh until she was back inside Darla. It wasn't the clones' fault that they had been raised to revere a leader as if it was a god. Horde Prime had committed many crimes, and while most wouldn't think what he had done to his clones was comparable to rendering entire planets and species extinct, Adora had to disagree. The way he had raised his clones, shaped them - indoctrinated them so they would blindly follow him, even at the cost of their lives, thinking it was a great honour to serve as his vessel… She couldn't help thinking of her own training. And what she might have done, not knowing any better, if she hadn't found the sword. And if she hadn't met Glimmer and Bow.

At least WrongHordak and Second Fleet showed that they could change - and grow past their conditioning. Even First Fleet's remnants were, in a way, encouraging with their reluctance to commit to the Alliance - they were not blindly following a leader any more.

“Cheer up! At least they’ll keep it safe. Unlike everyone else,” Catra told her with a scoff.

As usual, she knew what Adora was thinking. Then again, everyone knew how Adora thought about the clones worshipping her. Even the clones, but they somehow ignored it completely.

Although… “That’s unfair. We don’t know what happened in Egypt or in Honduras,” Adora said with a slight frown.

Catra shrugged and stretched her hands over her head, stretching. “We do know that the relics or whatcha call them weren’t kept safe.”

“The people on Earth didn’t know about them until we told them,” Adora pointed out.

“Details, details. Our success rate is a hundred per cent, and theirs is… zilch?” Catra retorted as they entered the bridge.

“SG-1 has a great success rate when it comes to handling alien technology,” Jack told them with a frown.

“Too bad your planet is ruining it,” Catra shot back.

“Well, you wanted to deal with the entire planet.” Jack bared his teeth in a grin.

Catra narrowed her eyes and flashed her fangs in return. “Who let a Goa’uld create a cult under their nose?”

“Oh, stop it, you two!” Glimmer snapped. “We have a country to save, and we don’t need this posturing.”

“Yes,” Adora agreed. “Did we get any more information about what’s going on while we handed over the container and the Death Glider?”

“No,” Catra said.

“You weren’t on the bridge,” Jack pointed out.

“I’ve got good ears,” Adora’s friend told him.

Glimmer loudly sighed. “Nothing concrete. Just more translations of what’s basically screaming and crying about the ‘walking dead’.”

“Zombies,” Jack said. “The walking dead are zombies.”

“Zombies are fictional, Sir,” Sam told him. “And, seeing as Earth’s magic hasn’t been activated, we can rule out a magical origin of whatever is happening in Honduras.”

“Unless someone sneaked out and did the magic thing,” Jack said - looking at Adora.

She glared at him. “I wouldn’t do that behind your back!”

“But you would do it against our will.” He stared at her.

“Many people on Earth want magic returned,” Adora said. “We know that.”

“From your own television,” Catra added with a grin.

“Many don’t want magic to make a return,” Jack countered.

“Too bad for them,” Glimmer said. “They don’t have to use magic if they don’t want to, but they don’t get to forbid others from having magic returned to them.”

“Ah, that’s oversimplifying things, I think. The matter is more complex. Even those who do not want to use magic will see it used on them.” Daniel smiled weakly. “And they are afraid of that.”

“You shouldn’t make decisions motivated by fear,” Entrapta cut in. “They tend to be illogical. And usually bad for you.”

“Yes,” Adora said, nodding firmly. “From what we can tell, the same people who fear magic also fear gays.”

"Or science," Entrapta added.

"So, screw them!" Catra grinned. "We're not going to listen to those idiots."

Jack pressed his lips together.

Daniel frowned. "Their fear might be irrational, but it's still something to take into account. The world is complex, and simple solutions often turn out to have unintended consequences."

"Sometimes, it's not about what's simple or complex, but what's right and wrong," Adora told him. "Just as we won't let others tell us who we can love, we won't let them tell us that we can't return magic to Earth. Not when people on Earth want it back. It's their birthright."

"Think of it as returning something that was stolen from Earth a thousand years ago," Catra said. "Oh, wait - returning stolen things, that's also a complex problem on Earth, isn't it?"

Jack glared but didn't say anything. Daniel, though, dug his heels in. "It's not quite that simple. In the past…"

"Hello! We're about to land in Honduras!" Glimmer interrupted him. "You can argue about magic and stolen goods once we've solved the problem!"

Adora nodded, once again in agreement with her friend. Saving people came first.

*****

Reserva de la Biosfera de Río Plátano, Honduras, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Alright, let's meet the locals! Let's hope they're friendlier than the last batch."

Samantha Carter smiled wryly at the Colonel's comment as the ramp of the ship started to extend. It wasn't entirely the Egyptians' fault that they had parted on less than cordial terms.

"Well, if you're polite and friendly, it's generally reciprocated," Daniel said.

"I'm very friendly," the Colonel replied.

"Not everyone has the same cultural norms, Jack. What you consider friendly might be seen as rude by others," Daniel retorted. "The stereotype of rude Americans exists for a reason."

"Technically, we're in America," the Colonel said.

"Central America. The people here have had some unfortunate experiences with the United States policies in the past," Daniel said. "And some might carry a grudge."

Sam was all too aware of that. And she was certain that the Colonel knew it as well - he might have been involved in some of it, in the past - his file had a lot of classified parts, as she knew from testing Stargate Command's computer security. But she also didn't expect the Colonel to change his general approach to meeting new people. That just wasn't him.

"Great," Glimmer commented with a sigh. "More old grudges."

"People should learn to let go of the past," Entrapta said. "You shouldn't let past grievances define your future."

"Well… there's a saying: Those who forget history are doomed to repeat it," Daniel said.

"And there's another saying: Don't waste time when you're under attack," Catra cut in.

The ramp touched the ground, and the airlock opened. The Colonel was first out of the door, walking with an easy gait. Sam

narrowed her eyes. Something was different. She couldn't put her finger on it, but the Colonel was… not off. Just different.

Four people were waiting at the edge of the landing site. One of them would be the local commander of the Honduran Army - probably the major to the right. The general next to him was too old to be in the field - and too high in rank. There was a captain, probably an aide, and a man in camouflage clothes without any rank insignia.

And the Colonel tensed. That was a bad sign.

"Hello!" Adora said - she must have missed that. "I'm She-Ra." She proceeded to introduce everyone.

"I'm General Bonilla." The older officer nodded at everyone. "These are Major Reyes, commander of our forces in the area, Captain Benìtez and…"

"Burke," the Colonel spat.

"O'Neill." The man - apparently Burke - replied with a glare.

"You know each other?"

"Yes."

"Jack?" Daniel asked.

"Classified."

"Oh."

Burke snorted.

"Ah." The general looked from the Colonel to Burke and back. "This won't be a problem, I hope."

"No." "No."

Sam hoped that neither was lying.

“So, you’ve got a zombie problem?” the Colonel nodded at Bonilla.

“We have a problem,” Bonilla replied, gesturing towards a tent nearby - a mobile command centre. As they walked over, the general continued: “We’ve sent forces into the reserve to secure the site of the alien artefact. They had strict orders to avoid contact with any piece of technology - observing and guarding only. But soon after entering the area in question, they reported a clash with unknown forces. The officer in charge considered them to be bandits or poachers.”

“Or guerrillas,” Burke commented.

“We don’t have guerillas in Honduras,” the general replied with a frown. “In any case, soon afterwards, we received the reports you already saw and then lost contact completely.”

They reached the tent, and two soldiers drew the flaps back for them. Inside was a rather modern radio and computer centre - Sam honestly hadn’t expected that kind of quality here. She saw top of the line encryption gear - even SG-1 didn’t have anything better except for what they had constructed themselves using advanced technology.

“So… what’s so important that Uncle Sam sprang for all of this?” the Colonel asked Burke, nodding at the gear.

The Honduran officers glanced at each other. The soldiers present carefully didn’t look at anything except their screens.

“Uncle Sam?” Adora asked. “The United States?”

“We’ve been running a clean-up operation here,” Burke said.

“‘Clean-up’ operation?” The Colonel snorted. “Some formerContras going freelance for the Cartels?”

Burke grinned, which was probably answer enough.

“So, your troops got wasted by veterans from the Nicaraguan civil war, and now they control the alien technology.” The Colonel sighed.

“We don’t know the identity of the forces in question,” Bonilla insisted.

“Well, we’ll find out.”

“So, we’ll have to fight bandits over alien technology.” Catra chuckled. “That brings back memories.”

Adora groaned. “At least it’s not a desert.”

“I’d prefer a desert - fewer places to hide,” Catra said.

“Our scanners show the location of every concentration of Naquadah in the area,” Sam spoke up. “But they won’t detect humans who aren’t using the technology. And we haven’t detected anything that would explain those reports of ‘zombies’.” Sam pressed her lips together. She didn’t like using this terminology, but if she used a more technical term, the Colonel would joke about it and call it zombies anyway.

Catra stretched her arms over her head - and that did attract the attention of the soldiers near them, Sam noticed - and yawned. “Well, whatever it is, we’ll deal with it.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. “We won’t leave you to deal with this, trust us.”

That was potentially stretching their mission objective. On the other hand, Sam expected whatever was posing as zombies to fall under the definition of alien technology anyway.

But the Hondurans smiled - for the first time since they had met. Burke, though, was scowling.

*****

“The Naquadah concentration is now directly below us,” Entrapta announced.

‘Below us’ apparently meant ‘below in the jungle, hidden by the trees’. Catra shook her head. She had been right - a desert would’ve been much better. You couldn’t hide as well in a desert. “So, let’s land?” she asked. “Darla can crush the trees beneath her, right?”

“But that could damage the landing gear!” Entrapta protested. “And all the crushed trees could block something!” She blinked. “And there are people below us,” she added belatedly, tapping a few keys on the console with her hair. “Dozens of them.”

“Some might be civilians. Or captives,” O’Neill said.

Burke, standing next to him, nodded.

“We weren’t going to land directly on top of them,” Catra replied while she rolled her eyes. Even if there were no people around, that would be a bad idea since they didn’t know what the device did. “Just land nearby.”

“That would still crush a lot of trees. It’s a nature reserve,” Daniel pointed out. Then he blinked and blushed a little.

“I doubt that this would do enough damage to be noticeable,” O’Neill said. “It’s a big reserve.”

“We would consider this an acceptable sacrifice,” Reyes said. “We’ve cleared landing zones for helicopters as well if we needed them.”

“Sir? Scanners are showing unidentified radiation,” Sam said.

“Radiation?” O’Neill tensed.

“Yes,” Entrapta added, cocking her head to look at the screens in front of her and Sam. “It’s not radioactivity, though. It seems…

magical in nature. Yes," she added after the screens flickered in rapid succession, "definitely magical."

"I thought magic didn't work on Earth without Adora… unblocking it?" O'Neill asked.

"Well, sorcery and most powers of princesses won't work," Entrapta explained. "Those rely on the magic field generated by life on a planet. But magical devices, unless constructed to rely on that field as well, work as long as they have another source of power." She smiled. "And no one would construct magic devices that only worked on a planet if they went to space!"

"Great. So we could have magic zombies running around," O'Neill commented.

"What?" Burke blurted out. "You're bullshitting me!"

O'Neill turned to glare at him. "You're surrounded by magical princesses, Burke. She-Ra here could turn an aircraft carrier into a plant. A few zombies wouldn't strain her."

"I wouldn't create such creatures!" Adora protested.

"It was just an example," O'Neill retorted.

"A stupid example!" Adora frowned.

Catra nodded in agreement. Adora didn't create monsters - she killed them. And she healed people and kingdoms. "What kind of magic is it?"

Entrapta wrinkled her nose. "It's… healing magic."

Catra blinked, surprised. "Healing magic?" That was a good thing, wasn't it?

"Very strong healing magic," Entrapta went on. "It's healing all damage suffered by living organisms in the area of effect."

“Then there’ll be some very healthy wildlife down there,” O’Neill said. “But that doesn’t explain zombies.”

“Unless the magic has side effects,” Sam speculated. “If it induces a trance while it works, and if it’s strong enough to heal bullet wounds, the effect could look like… zombies.”

“But wouldn’t that have affected our troops as well?” Reyes asked. He looked a little queasy.

“Well…” Entrapta bit her lower lip. “If they were caught at the edge of the area of effect, they wouldn’t be affected. Though…” She turned away and checked the screens again. “Oh. It’s spreading. The magical field, that is.” She beamed at them. “So, they encounter tranced people, shoot at them - the tranced people shoot back maybe, we don’t know how functional they are, but shooting usually doesn’t take much cognitive activity - but the people inside the field are getting healed, and then the expanding field catches your soldiers, who then enter a trance as well and stop reporting.”

That sounded like a good theory, in Catra’s opinion.

“It’s expanding? At what rate?” Reyes asked.

“And is it affecting us?” O’Neill added.

“We’re too high above the ground to be affected,” Entrapta replied. “And our shields should block the radiation. If we tweak them a little.”

“But the rate of expansion is growing,” Sam added before Catra could feel much relief.

“So, if the theory is true, we can’t approach the device without being turned into zombies,” O’Neill said. “Great. How do we stop it before Honduras is zombified?”

Reyes gasped at that. “We need to bomb it! We cannot risk that! Nuclear bombs, if needed!”

And Daniel gasped at that.

“Don’t worry - there’s one who can work safely inside the area of effect!” Entrapta announced.

“Me!” Adora nodded with a grim expression.

“You might be able to ignore the magic, yes,” Entrapta said, nodding. “But I was talking about Emily!”

“Oh.” Adora looked almost disappointed.

Catra shook her head at her stupid lover. “Yes, this sounds like a job for Emily.”

“Emily?” Reyes asked, looking around on the bridge.

“She’s a bot!” Entrapta explained. “Not organic, and her hull has been strengthened to be fully sealed. She can walk into the affected area and contain the device.”

“Or destroy it with her laser cannon,” O’Neill added.

“It’s actually a blaster cannon,” Entrapta corrected him. “But that depends on how tough the device is.”

“But if it carries it back to us…” Reyes trailed off.

“Oh, don’t worry - we’ll build a containment device that will block the healing energy.” Entrapta grabbed Sam’s hand with her hair. “No time to lose! To the lab!”

O’Neill stared as Sam was all but dragged off. “What kind of shows did you let her watch?” he asked.

Catra gave him a look. “Don’t blame your entertainment on us.”

*****

When Jack O’Neill had been told by General Hammond about this mission and how urgent it was, he had imagined quite a few

things. Like fighting a zombie plague in the jungles of Honduras, shooting the walking dead and blowing them up, maybe desperately holding the line while Carter and Entrapta tried to defuse some evil artefact. Or charge some magic thingie to wipe out all the zombies.

Safely waiting on the bridge of a spaceship high above the jungle while Carter and Entrapta prepared a robot to go and retrieve the artefact hadn't been amongst his ideas. Though maybe it should have been, given what he knew about the Etherians. Still, he had at least expected to stand next to Adora when she did something impressive, not… watch from way behind the lines while others risked their lives. Or their… circuits? Crystals? Whatever robots used to think.

"So… is this how it works?"

Jack clenched his jaw. He also hadn't imagined meeting Burke on this mission. The bastard who 'mistakenly' shot Wood on their last op. Which never happened, of course, since there were no records of it.

"What do you mean?" Daniel asked.

Jack cursed inwardly. He should've told his team about Burke. But there hadn't been a good occasion since they had gone straight back in the air after meeting the Hondurans - he couldn't really call for a huddle and whisper explanations while the rest watched and wondered. Catra would probably blurt it out anyway just to see what would happen.

"I was called in to fight bandits or maybe zombies." Burke tapped the grenade launcher he was carrying. "I didn't expect to… watch a robot do the job, I guess. But maybe that's normal for you guys?"

"Ah." Daniel smiled. "Well, it's not abnormal, but usually, we…"

"That's classified," Jack snapped with a glare at his friend.

Daniel blinked. “But…”

Jack narrowed his eyes at him. For someone so smart, Daniel sometimes really failed to read the mood. “Past missions are classified.”

“Oh.”

Burke snorted, and Jack glared at him. The man was the last person who had any right to comment about classified missions.

Burke met his eyes, frowning as well, then looked away and scoffed.

“Oh,” Daniel repeated himself.

“Wow, you guys are tense,” Catra cut in. “Don’t start shooting up the bridge, you hear? If you want to fight it out, do it outside.”

“We’re not going to fight it out,” Burke said.

Jack snorted at that. He wouldn’t mind getting back at Burke for killing Wood, but they had a mission. Even though they were just about useless right now.

Burke stared at him again, and, once more, he looked away first. Jack hoped that the bastard felt at least guilty about what he had done.

“And we’re checking our targets carefully,” Jack couldn’t help adding.

Burke jerked at that but didn’t react any further.

At least Daniel, even though he looked confused, had the wits to keep silent.

Catra, though, didn’t. “Oh!” she almost crowed. “You already shot each other?”

"If I did, he'd be dead," Jack said, at the same time Burke said it as well.

Catra shook her head. "Whatever it is, keep it down." Then she tilted her head to the side. "Though… What was it, anyway? Did you have a nasty break-up? Cheated on the other?"

Jack stared at her. She sounded *sincere*. Did she really think Jack would have…? With Burke?

"What?" Burke blurted out. "How can you even suggest such a thing?" He sounded shocked.

Oh. Jack blinked as he understood - of course, Catra would assume that, given her history with Adora. And Burke must have missed that part about the Etherians. He smiled. "Ah, no, we never were together," he said, as innocently as he could. "I was already married when we met." He suppressed the brief guilt and pain he felt when he remembered how his marriage had ended. And why.

"What do you mean?" Burke snapped at him.

"Ah." Catra nodded. "Well, then I guess I can't give you any advice how to get over this." She nodded at them and turned away.

"What the fuck?" Burke cursed as soon as Catra had stepped away. "She just called us… And you acted as if that was OK!"

Jack grinned. "Why, Burke, is there anything wrong with it?"

"Yes!"

"Don't worry, I've got it on good authority that 'don't ask, don't tell' will be revoked as soon as possible. Being gay won't be grounds for being discharged any more."

"That's not…" Burke trailed off. "You're bullshitting me!"

He sounded both offended and almost glad, Jack noticed with surprise. About the bill being repealed, or about Jack bullshitting him?

"Actually, no," Daniel decided to cut in. "Equal rights for homosexual people is one of the conditions for an alliance with the Etherians. Haven't you heard about that?"

"I was busy in the jungle," Burke replied.

"You missed hearing about aliens?" Jack shook his head.

"I missed that detail," Burke retorted.

Like he had 'missed' that the guy in the jungle in front of him was Woods, not some guerilla. Jack stopped grinning. For a moment, Jack had felt like before the last op. Just bullshitting around with friends. But Burke wasn't a friend. Not any more.

Not since he murdered Woods and claimed he had mistaken him for an enemy. As if Burke would have made such a mistake. And if he had made such a mistake, he would've acted completely differently than he had when Jack had found them.

He turned away and watched the screen again. "I hope they'll hurry. The magic must be spreading."

*****

Waiting. Adora didn't like to wait. She was She-Ra. She should be doing something while danger was threatening people. Or wait for others to do something like… like…

"Oh, stop pacing!" Catra snapped.

Adora turned to frown at her friend. "But this wave is spreading below us! It's harming people as we wait!"

"They evacuated the surrounding area," Catra pointed out. "And the people inside the area of effect were already hurt before we

arrived.”

“It’s still spreading.”

“Slow enough so it won’t really pose a problem for a long time.” Catra shrugged. “So, stop fretting and let Entrapta and the others do their thing.”

“I should help them…” Adora eyed the door leading from the bridge to the rear of the vessel.

Catra rolled her eyes. “I think they’ll call if they need you.”

Adora pressed her lips together. She knew she wasn’t a genius like Entrapta or Sam. Or a techmaster like Bow. She could use her power as a princess, but she couldn’t build stuff. She was a brute. And she was utterly useless right now. She was…

…getting hit on the head?

“Stop brooding!” Catra glared at her. “You aren’t useless just because you can’t do everything by yourself.”

Adora bit down on what she was about to say, then sighed. Catra was right. “I know.” She sighed again. “But it doesn’t feel right.”

Catra shrugged. “Trust our friends to do their job and focus on yours.”

“I don’t have a job right now.” That was the problem!

Catra grinned, though. “What did Earcut teach us in cadet training?”

The grizzled instructor? Adora blinked. He had taught them melee combat - the basics of it. How would that be applicable… Oh!

Her lover grinned. “Yes. If you have nothing to do, rest. Soon enough, you’ll get another task. So, be a good cadet and rest.”

Adora scoffed. “Resting while below us, some harmful magic is spreading?”

“Oh, don’t worry,” Catra told her as she hooked an arm through Adora’s. “I’ll help.”

Oh. “But…”

“No buts! We’ll be good soldiers and rest now. And relax.”

And then Adora was pushed into the captain’s chair, and Catra planted herself in her lap. “You’ll relax even if I have to sit on you.”

“But…”

“No buts! We’ll wait until the others have the bot ready, like the veteran soldiers we are!”

She could easily push Catra off her lap. But… Her lover was right. She couldn’t do anything useful right now.

Grumbling, Adora tried to relax.

*****

“OK, I think I’ve nailed down the thaumaturgical frequency of the healing energy. Now we need to attune the crystal to it.”

Samantha Carter nodded. Once the crystal was attuned, it could be used to counter the energy, shielding an area from its effects. Or, if six such crystals were aligned in a cube - or along the hull of a bot - form a containment unit. Provided they had a sufficient power supply. “How do we power it? Emily’s main battery won’t last long if it has to counter the amount of radiation we’re registering.” Sam had studied the battery’s output.

Entrapta blinked. “Right. So, we could pack her hull with spare batteries - though that would only work for a limited amount of time, either.”

Sam nodded and quickly ran a few calculations. “If the power of the healing device remains steady, even six batteries would last barely long enough to reach the device and bring it back to us. No safety margin at all.” And from what she could tell, six batteries was about the maximum Emily could handle and still move.

“Yes.” Entrapta bit her lower lip.

“I vote for a bigger safety margin,” Bow spoke up. “Our plans tend to run into some hiccups.”

“Not always,” Entrapta retorted. “But often enough to plan for it, I guess. So… no battery packs.”

“I would suggest an alternative solution,” Hordak cut in. “If we connect Emily to the main reactor of Darla, the power should be sufficient to counter the device.

“Like, a long line?” Entrapta asked. “Like in that show?”

“Show?” Sam asked.

“A television show with huge bots running around fighting other constructs. They are supplied with power through giant power lines that they have to plug in.”

That sounded… weird. Sam couldn’t recall hearing about any such tv show. “The cable would be vulnerable,” she pointed out. Even bandits would have weapons that could damage such a cable.

“We could armour it, but that would mean it would be too heavy to be dragged along by Darla,” Entrapta mused. “And you can’t use wheels in the jungle to take the weight of an armoured power line. Maybe a bot to carry it?”

“We could send escorts to guard the cable,” Hordak suggested. “A few guard bots should be enough to discourage interference.”

“But we don’t have guard bots or bots to carry the cable. We would have to ask Third Fleet,” Bow said with a grimace.

The others looked torn as well, Sam noticed. Well, that was understandable. Third Fleet was run by fanatics, after all. And in the current political situation, it wouldn't take much to set off another powder keg. Although… "What about wireless power transfer?" she asked. "If we add another crystal to act as a conduit and attune all of them to each other…" The crystals were linked and sharing power, after all, and the range of the synchronisation effect should cover the entire area.

"Yes! That would work - they'd form a thaumaturgical grid and spread the power equally!" Entrapta cheered. "And the crystal would act as an additional shield for Darla. And us. Let's do it!"

As the princess rushed to the side of the hold where the crystals were stored, Bow smiled at Sam. "That was a good idea. How did you come up with it?"

"People are working on wireless power transfers. I just applied the basic principles to enchanting," Sam replied. It still felt weird to talk about magic like this. Then again, magic was a bit of a misnomer - it worked according to rules and could be experimented with. It was a form of advanced technology following general principles. Principles Sam still had yet to fully learn in some cases, though.

"Ah!" Bow nodded. "I guess once Earth's magic is restored, you'll produce more such devices."

Sam pressed her lips together for a moment. 'Once Earth's magic is restored'... That was a touchy subject, to say the least. "A lot of people would start research into magic," she said. "And not all of them would be good people."

Bow shrugged. "That can't be helped. But how many of them are as smart as you are? They would have to start without any information about magic, either. Just like your sorcerers won't be able to do much for quite some time. Not without help from Mystacore."

Sam knew that she was smarter than most other scientists. It wasn't arrogance - she was well aware that she was exceptional. "But there are too many who will work on this. Some of them will have ideas that pay out. And some will cause problems."

Bow nodded. "But you can handle those."

He sounded very confident. Sam wished she shared his confidence. And yet… thaumaturgical technology offered so many possibilities…

*****

"Alright! Go, Emily! Don't be afraid - the magic can't hurt you!"

The massive bot beeped in return, turned in place, then started to head down the ramp. Catra watched it touch the ground and then stalk into the jungle.

"Power transmission is steady," Carter announced from the hold behind her. "Fluctuations are within the expected range."

"Good! Emily's a good bot; she'll do her job!" Entrapta said, nodding firmly.

But Catra didn't miss how her friend bit her lower lip when she turned to look at the screens. She was worried, then.

"If anything happens, I can retrieve her," Adora said. Apparently, she hadn't missed that either.

Catra clenched her teeth. Adora didn't have to risk herself at every opportunity. But… Emily was not just a bot. She had been with them for years and was family for Entrapta. "We can send in a few more bots if anything happens to Emily," Catra said. "Anything that can stop her can also be a problem for us."

"I can handle much more than a bot!" Adora insisted.

Catra clenched her teeth again. It was true - but it was also stupid. “But we don’t know if you can resist the magic down there.”

“If I go into a trance, you can send bots to retrieve me,” Adora retorted with a pout.

“We don’t know what exactly the magic does - a trance is just a theory,” Catra pointed out.

“Yeah, let’s not be too hasty,” O’Neill chimed in. “Let’s stick to sending robots in before we risk people.”

“Emily isn’t just a bot!” Entrapta protested. “She’s not a tool - she has feelings!”

“Emotions?” Daniel tilted his head slightly to the side as he pushed his glasses up. “Simulated or… how does that work?”

“It’s a neural matrix, like a neural net,” Carter explained. “Artificial Intelligence research has been exploring such concepts for a while.”

“Yes,” Entrapta said. “Emily is smart. Smarter than many people.”

Catra bit her lower lips to keep herself from making a comment about Adora; it wouldn’t have been funny.

“So… are all your bots like that?” O’Neill asked.

“No,” Hordak said. “Many bots are just programmed with a set of instructions. Not every task needs intelligence. Often, it’s a hindrance. And it takes a lot of different experiences for neutral matrixes to adapt to and develop even rudimentary intelligence.”

O`Neill snorted and mumbled something about marines.

Entrapta shrugged. “And even Emily wasn’t as smart at the beginning - a neural matrix takes time to learn.” She smiled. “But she did learn!”

“So… those combat robots you mentioned are like… baby bots?” O’Neill looked queasy. As did Daniel. And Carter looked shocked.

Hordak, though, nodded. “Those with neural matrixes, yes. Although larvae would be a more correct term. They need stimuli to develop their cognitive facilities. Merely growing older won’t do anything.”

“But do they have a sense of self?” Daniel asked. “Once they are, ah, like Emily?”

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded.

“That throws up a lot of ethical questions,” Daniel commented.

“Why?” Hordak, of course, didn’t understand.

“Oh! Emily is approaching the device - the location from which the energy spreads!” Entrapta interurpted them. “Look at her go!”

The screen showed what the bot saw - with a map in the lower corner. She was breaking through the underbrush, shooting thicker trees if she needed to.

“Very effective. If the armour can withstand staff blasts, she will be a terror on the battlefield,” Teal’c commented.

“Yes! She’s got an experimental blaster cannon!” Entrapta beamed. “Go, Emily!”

The bot beeped in return.

And then she entered a clearing - a campsite. Or what was left of it. The tents were torn, and… there was a man standing next to a glowing cube within a cube-framework thingie. A bit bigger than a head, all in all. And he was armed with one of the Earth rifles. A different model than what SG-1 carried, Catra noticed.

“He’s shooting at Emily!” Entrapta complained.

And he was. Not that the rifle had any chance of hurting the bot. Catra had to give the man kudos for standing his ground, though - few soldiers would have managed that in the war. But… something was off. That was a weird trance.

Emily, meanwhile, ignored the man and walked past him to the cube, her hull opening and two metal tentacles shooting out of the bot's body to grab the cube. The man tried to stop her, but a quick jerk sent him flying into the underbrush.

Then the cube disappeared into Emily's body.

"Containment field active," Carter reported.

"And… no more healing magic radiation!" Entrapta announced with a smile. "Our plan worked."

"Someone needs to tell the guy that," O'Neill said. "He seems to have missed the memo."

And indeed - on the screen, Catra saw the man stumble out of the bush and attack Emily again. And… "His eyes. Check his eyes," she said.

Entrapta frowned, but Emily zoomed in on the man's face.

His eyes were white and looked… wrong. And his throat…

"I think the healing energy did more than just trancing people," Hordak commented.

*****

"No shit, Sherlock," Jack O'Neill blurted out before he could stop himself. The man on the screen - probably one of the 'bandits'; his uniform didn't match the Honduran fatigues - had a piece of wood embedded in his throat. He hadn't turned yet, so Jack couldn't check if it went all the way through, but the way it stuck out of the throat… "Even if the wound were healed around that, he couldn't breathe properly."

Daniel looked at Jack with a disturbed expression. "Ah…"

"Speaking from personal experience?" Catra asked.

"Not on the receiving end, no," Jack replied.

"Ah."

"What's a Sherlock?" Hordak asked.

"A fictional character renowned for his powers of observation," Daniel explained.

"Ah." The alien nodded. "Sarcasm, then."

Jack held his next comment back. "So… how long until the healing energy runs out?"

"Uh… it's no longer radiating," Entrapta said. "So…" She cocked her head sideways. "Perhaps some energy lingering in the body? Probably directly keeping the cells alive and working, so damage like that doesn't incapacitate him. But how do they control the body? Is the central nervous system still working? It must."

"He, uh, doesn't look particularly aware," Daniel pointed out.

The guy was still trying to stop the robot from walking away. Emphasis on trying. Jack made a mental note not to engage any robot with anything lighter than an RPG.

"Wait!" Carter snapped. "Move back to a shot of the man's chest and freeze the picture!"

"Alright!" Entrapta's hair tentacles flew over the console, and the screen changed.

Catra whistled. "Either the man picked his uniform fresh from the morgue, or he was shot earlier."

She was right - Jack could see holes in the man's top, some covered with dried blood. "So it is a zombie."

“We don’t know that!” Daniel objected. “He could’ve been healed before death happened.”

“We need to scan him closely,” Carter said. “We need to find out what happened - and how we can deal with it. Sir,” she added belatedly.

Jack nodded, overlooking the slight lapse. “Yes. So, how do we do that?” He wasn’t keen on entering the zombie area even with the thingie contained. Who knew how many animals had been affected? Would zombie mosquitos still suck your blood, or would they go for your brain fluid?

“I can go grab him!” Adora offered.

“Or we can just let Emily lure the man to us,” Catra objected. “No need to expose ourselves.”

“Right. He can’t really hurt Emily,” Entrapta agreed. “And he seems to have run out of ammunition. That’s a drawback with your weapons.”

“He would’ve run out of power as well with a Horde laser rifle,” Catra pointed out.

“Right. Still…”

“Can we focus on capturing the zombie?” Jack asked. This wasn’t the time to discuss weapon technology and doctrine.

“Possible zombie. We don’t know what happened. All we know is that he’s a victim of alien technology,” Daniel said.

Jack rolled his eyes.

“And we need to track the other victims,” Glimmer spoke up. “If they wander off…”

“We don’t want a zombie apocalypse.” Jack nodded. He noticed that Burke was staring at all of them and snorted. “Welcome to

the galaxy."

The mangled quote shook Burke out of his apparent shock. "What the hell is going on, Jack?"

"You heard the scientists: Possible zombie plague." Jack shrugged with more nonchalance than he felt. "Just wait until they tell us how to deal with them."

"What?" Burke shook his head. "Since when do you trust the brass about intel?"

"Since working with Stargate Command," Jack told him in a flat tone. His team had never let him down. Or shot each other.

"Lucky you," Burke spat.

"Well, if you don't 'mistake' your teammate for an enemy and shoot them, people tend to trust you with more than some shitty counter-terrorism mission in the ass-end of nowhere," Jack shot back. All this jungle needed to recreate Vietnam were some rice fields. And a horde of Viet Cong trying to kill you.

Burke glared at him again, opened his mouth, but closed it without more than a muttered curse.

Jack scoffed. Couldn't even defend himself.

"It wasn't like that!" Burke blurted out as if he had read Jack's mind. "Wood was about to shoot me."

"Really?" Jack scoffed again. "And you forgot to mention that at the court-martial?"

"I couldn't say anything! It would have cost Cindy his pension!"

Cindy? Jack blinked. Who was Cindy? Then he remembered. Cindy Wood. The widow. "What?"

“He was going to shoot me because I discovered that he was selling us out,” Burke snapped. “I was faster than him. But if he had been exposed as a traitor, Cindy would have lost his pension.”

“What?” Jack stared at him. “Wood was trying to sell us out, and you kept quiet about it?” For his widow?

“What good would have come of it?” Burke shrugged. “Wood was dead, and I knew you weren’t a traitor, so there was no other leak.”

Well, of course Jack wasn’t a traitor! But… Burke trusted him? Well, he should have. Jack still felt some guilt. “You should have said something anyway,” he said.

“You knew Cindy. Would you have said anything?” Burke shot back.

Would he have said anything? Jack hesitated. That had been a different time. He had just married; Charlie hadn’t been born yet… Would he have said anything?

Burke nodded as if Jack had given him an answer. Damn jerk.

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The Naquadah Crisis Part 6

Reserva de la Biosfera de Río Plátano, Honduras, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Are they going to fight?" Adora asked in a low voice, looking at Jack and Burke in the corner across the hold. They had been staring at each other ever since they had met today. A lot of tension, but she couldn't quite place what kind of tension.

"Ah, they seem to be making up," Catra whispered next to her.

"Oh?" Adora turned to look at her lover. "So, they were…?"

Catra tilted her head to the side. "I don't think so. Just friends who had a falling out over a dumb secret or something."

"Ah." Adora envied Catra's ears at times. She had had no clue - well, some clues, but nothing that would help - about this whole thing. "So, they're good now?"

"Dunno." Catra shrugged. "Hard to tell."

Adora scoffed. Well, if they hadn't made up, that was their problem. Emily was almost at the ship. She cleared her throat. "We need to catch the… suspect now." She pressed her lips together - she should have thought of a good name for their target before speaking.

"Let's just call him zombie guy," Jack said, grinning.

"We're not calling him 'zombie guy'," Glimmer said with a glare at him.

"What about 'specimen number one'?" Entrapta asked - honestly; Adora could tell.

"Are you really arguing about what to call a walking dead?" Burke asked - the man was, again, looking shocked.

“Yes?” Jack looked at him as if he couldn’t understand why Burke would ask that. But that was an act. At least Adora was pretty sure it was an act. “The correct nomenclature is very important in our line of work.”

Yes, definitely an act. Adora shook her head.

“Jack!” Daniel protested.

“What? Don’t you always insist on using the correct terminology?”

“Emily is almost back with us,” Hordak cut in. “We should focus on dealing with the threat instead of on what to call it.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. “And since we’re not in the range of the healing energy - which isn’t spreading any more, right?” she added with a glance at Entrapta and Sam.

“It has disappeared,” Sam confirmed.

“Right. So, I can go and just grab the man,” she said. “If he can’t hurt Emily, he can’t hurt me.”

“Unless it’s some infectious disease,” Entrapta said.

“What?”

“Well, we haven’t detected any pathogen or viruses,” her friend explained, “but that’s one possible cause for such behaviour - at least according to Earth myth.”

“That’s Hollywood,” Daniel said. “I wouldn’t assume that there’s any base in reality for that.”

“There are parasites that can change human behaviour,” Sam added. “But we haven’t detected anything - simply magical radiation. Healing magic.”

And Adora was all about healing magic. Amongst other things. “Either way, I’m the best choice for this.”

She looked at Catra, who sighed and nodded. “I guess so - if there are no germs.”

“There shouldn’t be.”

“Biological warfare…” The Honduran officer shook his head. Adora had almost forgotten that they had guests around.

“Nothing we can’t handle,” Jack said with a wide smile.

Adora nodded. She could heal entire countries, after all. Granted, that had been a special occasion, but she was She-Ra. She could do this. “I’m going to fetch the man. And hold him outside while you deal with the device.”

“We’ll prepare the containment unit!” Entrapta said. “And the containment unit for the affected human!”

Adora nodded and headed to the airlock.

Catra followed her. And Melog followed them.

Adora looked at her lover.

“I’m not going to join you,” Catra told her with a wry grin. “But I’ll be waiting here.”

“Ah.” She nodded at Catra, then bent forward and placed a quick kiss on her lover’s head. “I’ll be right back.”

“I’ll hold you that, dummy.” Behind her, Melog glowed.

Adora stepped outside, jumping off the ramp. Emily was approaching - and the man was still trying to stop her - even though all he was doing was hugging one of her legs now. It was almost too easy - she grabbed him by the scruff of his neck and pulled him away, ignoring his flailing. “All done, Emily.”

Emily beeped in return and entered the ship.

Adora took a closer look at her captive - and grimaced at the sight. The piece of wood had gone through his entire throat. Jack had been correct - there was no way he could breathe like this. And his eyes were white. Not glowing, not like when someone was possessed, but… not natural, either.

What kind of healing magic could do this? And could she do such a thing by accident as well?

That was a disturbing thought. Very disturbing. She didn't remember any such incident - but would she have noticed if she had done this to some animals when she healed the Fright Zone?

"We've secured the device," Catra yelled from the ramp. "Melog doesn't sense anything, either. You can bring the zombie inside."

Adora didn't protest the name as she carried the man - or former man - inside and dropped him in an airtight cell Entrapta and Sam had prepared.

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"Oh. The cells are all alive, but the brain is not working at all. The brain cells are working individually, but there's no trace of a neural network. It's like a colony of single-cell organisms all working in concert without a discernable biological directive. This is so fascinating." Entrapta all but cooed, Samantha Carter saw. Then the princess blinked. "I mean, it's horrible that this happened to a person, but the result is fascinating. In a horrible way." Entrapta's smile looked more than a little forced.

But Sam could understand the feeling. Did understand it - this 'zombie' was, from a strictly scientific point of view, fascinating indeed. And horrible. "So, they must be controlled by magic - the human organism couldn't, without a working nervous system, move at all, much less in the way we've observed."

"Exactly! Our sensors show a magic field around the body, focused on damaged cells. See how the field is stronger at the

wrists and ankles? It must be repairing the damage done to the body by the attempts to break free."

Sam nodded - she could see that the man - or, now confirmed, corpse - in the cell in front of them was struggling against the thick metal bands that held him, baring his teeth but not making any discernible sounds. Just like a zombie in those cheap horror movies she had watched in college. "So… can we save him?"

"Restore higher brain functions? Or any brain functions at all?" Entrapta cocked her head as her hair moved over the console, pushing buttons.

The things she could do with such hair… Sam suppressed a brief, weird bout of envy. "Yes." That would be… Well, the Colonel would probably call it resurrection. Or 'de-zombification or something similarly silly.

Entrapta shook her head with a sigh. "I don't think so. I doubt we can restore the network that, well, made him him. I doubt that we could even restore the basic brain functions that keep the body alive and breathing - the magic healing must have completely disrupted it."

"Well, that can be relearned," Hordak said. "Or we could attempt to copy an existing lower-level network pattern onto a clean brain."

Sam's eyes widened at the proposal. "What? You want to copy a person's mind?"

Hordak frowned at her. "Of course not - we don't have the technology or magic to achieve such a feat. But we might be able to copy a less complex pattern well enough to speed a relearning process along."

"Uh, I don't think that's a good idea. In fact, I think that's a very bad idea," Bow cut in.

"Yeah," Entrapta agreed. "Even if we manage to copy a pattern well enough to imprint on a brain, the new brain cells will be trying to copy actions from another body. That won't work on that level, much less a higher one."

"True," Hordak agreed with a frown. "I forgot that this wouldn't be a basic clone pattern."

"Oh." Bow looked at Entrapta with a grimace, Sam noticed. And Entrpata nodded with a… sad expression?

Ah. That must be how Horde Prime's clones had been… programmed was the word, even though, or especially, since it was dehumanising. Sam cleared her throat. "So, we could only create a new person in an old body."

"More or less. Like a baby. Just with a larger body," Entrapta nodded.

"Well, I don't know about you, but I'm not ready to become a father right now," Bow said with a weak grin. "So… I don't think we should create a new life here."

Sam winced at the implications.

"Right!" Entrapta nodded again. "If we do make a baby, it won't be in the middle of an experiment."

"Yes," Hordak agreed.

Sam glanced at Bow. He looked as disturbed about this exchange as she felt. But they had a task to do. "So… this healing energy disrupted the neural network in people's brains - presumably in other creatures as well?"

"I think so… some of the more primitive creatures might not be affected, and some at the outskirts of the field might not have suffered complete disruption, but those in close vicinity…" She shook her head. "Probably gone."

“So, we have a zombie area in the jungle,” Bow said. “Why would anyone do this?”

“I think a lower-powered application would restore a body without wiping the neural networks controlling it,” Hordak said. “The network would still suffer some degeneration, but it would, properly controlled, not be significant unless someone was repeatedly exposed to such magic.”

“Does that mean that magical healing damages your brain?” Sam asked.

“This form of magical healing does,” Entrapta replied.

“People have been healed repeatedly during the war without suffering such effects,” Bow pointed out. “And I don’t recall any lecture about such a risk. It must be unique to this device.”

That was a relief. And yet… “We still have an unknown number of such affected people and animals to deal with,” she said.

The others nodded.

“We might consider using a bomb, as was suggested by the representative of the local population,” Hordak.

“I don’t think we should nuke part of Honduras,” Sam retorted.

They had to find a better way to deal with this… zombie infestation.

“Well, we could just wait until the magic effect fades - it takes a lot of energy to keep all the individual cells not only alive, but working together, and without the device to provide the energy, it’ll shut down sooner or later - I guess we can calculate a rate of decay if we get more data,” Entrapta said.

That was a better solution - provided that this ‘sooner or later’ was sooner rather than later. Sam doubted that the Hondurans wanted to cordon off the entire area for a decade or two. But she

needed more than a theory to suggest a course of action to the Colonel. "Let's check."

"Yes!" Entrapta whirled and started using her instruments again. Sam stepped up to the console and added some calibrations.

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"...and our conclusion is, although based on only one set of data and extrapolated, accounting for the lack of a natural magic field and the interaction between the magic and the internal chemical energy reserves of the cells, that the affected organisms should stop being able to move in about two days to a week. It depends on how much energy they use to move, so more primitive organisms could function for a longer time while people and similar creatures wouldn't last too long," Entrapta explained.

Catra blinked. "So, we just have to wait, and the problem solves itself?" That was convenient!

"Yes," Entrapta replied, nodding.

"Although we cannot completely exclude the possibility that the affected organisms might display unexpected characteristics in the meantime," Carter added. "They might mutate with all the magic energy affecting every cell."

"Mutant zombie mice?" O'Neill asked, shaking his head. "If we tell Hammond that there's a danger of that, we'll get sent to a shrink."

"I think General Hammond will not dismiss the possibility of such a threat after studying our other reports," Teal'c commented.

"Yeah, I was trying to make light of the fact that we have a bunch of effectively dead people walking around without a chance of curing them." O'Neill sighed. "So much for magic healing."

Catra saw Adora flinch and clenched her teeth. How dare he! "That wasn't the fault of healing magic!" she snapped. "That was

the fault of an idiot creating a dangerous artefact and another idiot turning it on! Don’t blame magic healing for this!”

O’Neill turned to frown at her. “Hey! I’m the one who was healed by magic here - I’ve got a right to be concerned.”

She hissed. “I was brought back from death by Adora’s magic! You just got healed!”

He recoiled a little, then dug in his heels. “Then you should be concerned as well!”

“No, neither of you should be concerned,” Entrapta cut in. “If Adora’s healing had such side effects, we would have noticed them long ago - she did restore the Fright Zone, after all, and healed the forest in Plumeria. If there was anything wrong, Perfuma would have noticed.”

“Yes, I think we would have noticed zombie animals wandering around,” Glimmer said. “Also, I’m a trained sorceress.” She raised her hand. “Mystacore’s best sorcerers tested for negative effects of ‘overhealing’ long ago and found nothing with the standard healing spells.”

“Well, something went wrong here,” Daniel pointed out. “So, there is a danger even if you didn’t encounter it before. Adora’s healing is safe, but what if anyone else tries to invent a new way of magic healing?”

Catra heard O’Neill mutter something about unsafe magic and clenched her teeth again. Working with this kind of attitude was so frustrating! “We know what we are doing,” she said, flashing her fangs.

“But you want to restore magic to the world,” O’Neill shot back. “That means a lot of people who don’t know what they are doing will dabble with magic. Who’s to say that they won’t create a real zombie plague?”

Daniel, to Catra's surprise, nodded. "I have to agree. It seems that this was a localised effect dependent on a single item. But what if it could tap into a natural magic field to power itself?" He grimaced. "Like a magical zombie plague?"

"Zombie apocalypse," O'Neill added.

Glimmer shook her head. "That's not how it works. You don't realise just how difficult it is to create such devices as the one here. You can't just 'dabble' and create that by accident. And the idea that you could create a spell that does this…" She scoffed. "You might as well bang together a pair of rocks and hope to get a nuclear bomb out of it."

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta chimed in. "The thaumaturgic equations used here are incredibly ahead of anything else I've seen. This can serve as inspiration for so much research! Those Ancients were such geniuses!"

Catra had to wince at that. "But let's do any such research in space." Where they could blow up a lab if something got out of control. Melog agreed, she could feel them.

"Right. We really need a lab ship for research." Entrapta nodded.

"That sounds like a good idea," Daniel said. "But even if the risk is minimal, should you really unlock magic on Earth?"

Glimmer frowned at him. "Why not? It certainly didn't prevent this device from being created. Magic being returned to Earth just means that sorcery becomes possible."

"But this device was created when magic was available," Daniel retorted.

Carter cleared her throat. "We've been working with magic since we arrived on Earth. Our scanner works with magic but is powered by advanced technology. That's also how the containment fields work." She looked at O'Neill, Catra noticed, as she went on: "We're using magic. We're doing magic research."

"And you can bet that your government is already working out how to do magic research as well," Glimmer added.

"But we'll do it in a responsible manner!" O'Neill retorted.

Catra looked at Daniel, who winced, and then at Carter, who was not meeting anyone's eyes.

Yeah, right.

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Jack O'Neill suppressed a wince. Yeah, the United States weren't perfect, but if he had to choose who got to experiment with magic, he'd pick a government laboratory with good supervision over some weird New Age Wicca with a grudge against their neighbours any day of the week. "Generally, we'll do it in a more responsible manner than some random person on the street. Carter here answers to the government, for example, and the government answers to the people. That means Carter can't just decide to create magical kudzu and let it loose on the prized garden across the street." He grinned at her, "No matter how much you might want to after the last homeowner association meeting."

She smiled back at him, but he could tell she was… at least slightly annoyed. Even though he was absolutely sure she had thought about doing this at least once. Who hadn't?

Good enough, though. He nodded. "Anyway, the government might not be perfect, but our scientists have supervision. And budgets."

"That feels very restrictive," Entrapta said with a pout. "I don't think non-scientists are the best people to direct research. What if they don't understand the subject? Or have an irrational fear of the potential results?"

"Well," Jack replied. "The restrictions are kind of the point."

A point, or so he believed, judging by some of the glances exchanged between their friends, that the Etherians might accept.

"So much for free enterprise," Catra commented with a toothy grin.

"Well, most scholars would agree that no freedom is absolute, and ensuring the safety of the general population is usually a sufficient reason for proportionate and effective restrictions," Daniel remarked.

"Like no zombie plagues," Burke added.

Entrapta didn't seem to be convinced.

"Or not creating portals that might destroy the world," Glimmer added.

That made Entrapta flinch. "Oh, right."

And Catra flinched as well, Jack noticed.

"But you can't really control all research either," Glimmer pointed out. "Not unless you control every country and its population. Which you don't. And your governments do run secret research projects."

"Like Stargate Command," Adora added.

Jack managed not to wince at that. "Yeah, and imagine what would have happened if that project had been without any supervision or backup by the government. Anyway, how about we talk about this once we're sure the zombie-generator is safely stashed somewhere? Like between Earth and the Sun?"

"Good idea," Adora agreed.

"Yes," Reyes spoke up. "The sooner this is out of our country, the better."

And Jack suppressed a curse. The Honduran had stayed silent during their entire conversation. They hadn't exactly spilt classified information, but the officer would have gotten more insight into the Etherians - and SG-1 - than most people. Ah well, that couldn't be helped right now. Jack would claim it was a trust-building measure.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, August 19th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"We're in space. Like astronauts." Burke shook his head as he stared out of the window.

"Yep," Jack said as he stepped up next to the agent. "And it's cold out there." And hot if you were facing the sun, but Carter wasn't here to correct him.

Burke scoffed. "It might be old news to you, but to me…" He shook his head again. "I would have never expected to experience this."

"And you can't talk to anyone about it," Jack replied before he could help himself.

Burke snorted. "That's normal in our business."

"Yes. And speaking of your business… You aren't too attached to your cosy little jungle, are you?"

Burke narrowed his eyes at Jack. "What do you mean?"

"We're always on the lookout for people who don't freak out if they encounter aliens. Or zombies."

Burke snorted. "You mean I know too much to keep running black ops."

Jack shrugged. No sense in denying that - Burke knew how the game was played.

"I don't fancy having an accident on the next mission or getting kidnapped, so I guess I don't mind getting a new assignment." Burke glanced at the window again.

"Stargate Command doesn't do that kind of stuff," Jack told him.

"Sure you don't."

"No, really. We have ethical officers and staff who wouldn't look kindly on such antics," Jack explained.

"Ah." Burke looked at Daniel. "So, no one's going to off Reyes?"

"None of us, at least," Jack replied. Who could say what the NID or CIA would do? Jack hoped they would restrain themselves - the Etherians wouldn't be happy if they found out about such operations. He had stressed that in his reports.

"Ah."

"So, welcome aboard. Don't get taken over by space snakes," Jack said with a grin. Now he wouldn't have to feel guilty any more about thinking the worst of Burke for years. Though how could he have known that Burke wouldn't tell the truth at his own court-martial? He ignored the small voice in the back of his head that told him he should have known better since Burke had been a friend.

Burke nodded, smiling almost reluctantly as he looked at space again. And at the frigate they were currently docked with. "Do I get a laser gun?"

Jack grinned again. "Well, those are actually not as good as you might expect. We use carbines, rifles, SMGs - stuff you're familiar with."

"Really?"

Jack nodded. "And if we stick with the Etherians, swords and bows might make a comeback as well."

Burke blinked, then glanced at Bow, who was talking with Glimmer in the corner. And then back at Jack. "You're bullshitting me!"

Jack chuckled. "I sure hope so." He would make a very bad Green Arrow or Hawkeye.

They spent a few minutes stargazing - well, Jack was stargazing; he should have brought his telescope - before Carter, Entrapta and the others returned to the bridge.

"All set!" Entrapta announced. "It's not quite a secure lab, but the frigate will keep it safe, and with a bot crew, so even if the containment falls, they won't be affected."

"Good." Jack wasn't about to comment about how such setups never worked in the movies. "Then we can drop off the good Major now."

"And then go after the next Naquadah item!" Entrapta said.

"Which is classified," Catra quickly added before the princess could reveal even more to Reyes.

Jack nodded in agreement and turned to the Honduran. "Need to know and all, you know."

"Of course, Colonel."

Reyes was far too quiet for Jack's taste. He was sure that the man hadn't missed much. And since he had been in command of tracking down 'bandits', he might have a background in intelligence. Probably counter-intelligence.

Jack would be much happier once the man was off the ship.

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Over the Atlantic Ocean, Earth, Solar System, August 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“So, what’s next? Siberia or the ocean?” Adora asked as Darla kept hovering over the big ocean - Mermista would probably love to explore the sea here.

“Well, the UN Security Council is a bit torn on the issue. It looks like Russia and China want us to go after the thing in the ocean first,” Jack said.

“And the United States want us to secure the object in Siberia before the Russians do it, right?” Catra asked, leaning against Adora’s chair, her tail brushing against her leg from time to time.

Adora still hadn’t been able to make Catra admit that she was doing this intentionally.

“Yes.” Jack nodded.

“We could split up,” Bow suggested. “Go after both simultaneously.”

“I think it would be easier to head to Siberia,” Jack said. “Unless this ship can dive better than a submarine, you’ll need our help to reach that.”

“Well… if the depth is not too high, Darla should be able to withstand the pressure,” Entrapta said. “But she’s not really ready for operations under the sea.”

“We usually left that to Mermista and the Salineans,” Bow said.

“It’s kind of her shtick,” Catra added. “And she gets all huffed up if we don’t let her do all the water stuff.”

Adora frowned at her lover. That was a pretty biased description of Mermista. “It’s only logical that she would take care of such situations, like Perfuma handles plant problems.”

“Redundancy is a good thing,” Catra retorted. Adora didn’t believe her innocent expression.

Glimmer snorted. “Anyway, can we dive that deep?”

“I wouldn’t want to risk Darla. What if she springs a leak?” Entrapta said. “We could keep the shields up, but that would mean that we have trouble doing anything outside.”

“Or we could leave that to trained divers and submarines,” Jack suggested.

“Your divers aren’t trained in handling Goa’uld technology,” Hordak retorted. “What if they set up another explosion underwater?”

“The shockwave might even be able to cause a tsunami,” Carter said.

“I could make diving suits for us. It would take me some time, though,” Entrapta told them.

“That’s a good idea,” Glimmer said. “Just in case.”

“We could hit the Siberian location in the meantime,” Daniel said. “We can find it more easily than the Russians, right?”

“Oh, yes! We have determined its exact location with the last scan!” Entrapta said. She pointed at the hologram showing both locations with her hair. “It’s underground and in some tomb or other structure.”

“Is that a Goa’uld site or a facility run by the Russian government?” Jack asked.

“Uh… I can’t tell from here. It’s blocking our scans to some degree.”

“Which could indicate either,” Sam added before Adora had to ask. “It’s rather deep in the ground, Sir.”

“Well, my gut says Russian,” Jack commented.

“Are you sure that your gut isn’t stuck in the Cold War, Jack?” Daniel asked.

“Are you sure that the Russians aren’t back in the Cold War?” Jack snorted. “They want to use the alien technology to surpass us.”

“And we want the alien technology to keep our position,” Daniel retorted.

“And we need trustworthy allies to fight the Goa’uld and save the galaxy - and Earth,” Glimmer cut in. “So… can we hit this already?” She pointed at Siberia. “I don’t want to wait until your people make up their minds. This is too dangerous.”

“Don’t we have a mandate from the Security Council to secure all the technology we discovered?” Adora asked. That was what she had taken from the last meeting.

“Anything that isn’t already safe and secure,” Catra corrected her. “That was probably slipped in by the USA.” She flashed her fangs at Jack.

“But what technology we’ve recovered is already known. The Naquadah in Siberia is not known.”

“The Russians might have lied? I’m shocked!” Jack gasped and held a hand over his heart.

“You know, even at their worst, the Princess Alliance worked better than this,” Glimmer said, shaking her head.

“At their worst, the Alliance didn’t do anything,” Bow objected.

“That’s still better than working against each other,” Glimmer told him.

“Well…”

Adora cleared her throat. “Let’s tell the Russians we can assist them. And that we need to ensure we’re not dealing with another

‘zombie plague’.”

Jack grinned. And Catra patted Adora’s shoulder. “Who knew you could be sneaky!”

Adora frowned at her friend. She could be sneaky if she wanted to! She just usually didn’t want to - honesty was better than trying to trick people who were or could become friends.”

“Yeah, let’s head over to Russia with your shiny space ship with the space guns and tell the Russians we’re here to help,” Jack said. “Let’s see them try to tell us to get lost. Hey! Do you think we could land on the Red Square in Moscow first?”

“Jack!” Daniel protested. “We can’t just antagonise Russia!”

“We certainly can,” Jack said. He was grinning in a manner that reminded Adora of Catra when she was annoying people.

“We won’t annoy the Russians - or anyone else - unless we can help it,” Adora stated. “Darla, take us to Siberia.”

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North of Bratsk, Russia, Earth, Solar System, August 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“We’re right above the location,” Entrapta said. “I double-checked.”

Samantha Carter nodded. “Yes.” She had done the same. Just to be sure. Whoever had hidden the facility holding the Naquada artefact had done a thorough job - she couldn’t see any sign of it from above. Then again, if this was a Goa’uld site, the millennia since they had left Earth would have done most of the work. But if this was, as the Colonel suspected, a Russian installation… “Can we map the site?” she asked.

“Yes… although it has a really confusing layout. I cannot make out a pattern… Wait! Let’s scan for other metals!” Entrapta’s hair flew

over the console, pushing buttons and keys before Sam could react.

Other metal… Oh! "You think it's a mine?" Sam asked.

"Yes! That would explain why the tunnels aren't following logical patterns. So, there should be residual ore… Yes!" She beamed at Sam, then at Hordak. "It's an old mine!"

"And was it repurposed?" Sam asked. She eyed the screen. "Can we get more details here?"

"It's not shielded like a First One site, but the ore in the ground and the depth of the site make it hard to detect details," Entrapta explained. "Although… yes, this looks like the entrance."

On the main screen, the map zoomed in on a spot quite far away from the Naquadah's location. And that spot… there were no roads, but… Sam tilted her head. "That looks like tracks."

"Yes. All-terrain vehicles," Hordak agreed. "Someone has been visiting the site recently, or they would've been covered by vegetation again."

"Right. Without Perfuma, you can't easily erase such tracks," Entrapta said.

"There are ways to hide your tracks," Sam corrected her. "But they aren't perfect." And the closer you were to the hidden tracks - or the better your instruments - the harder it was to hide them.

"Right! So… someone's down there. Bandits?"

Bandits? Russia had a problem with organised crime and corruption, but Sam didn't think this was related to either. "I think it's more likely that this is a site controlled by the Russian government - or part of it."

"In that case, we should proceed with caution," Hordak said. "We wouldn't want to accidentally kill government troops."

Or not so accidentally. In any case, they had found the entrance. Sam suppressed a sigh - they had to call the others, who were currently resting. She knew the Colonel needed more sleep, but they couldn't risk another Egypt. "Let's call the others," she said.

"Yes!" Entrapta hit the button for the intercom. "Everyone! We found the entrance!"

Not even a minute later, the Colonel and the others entered the hold. "So, what have you scienced up?" he asked with a grin that didn't quite manage to hide how tired he was.

"We found the entrance to the installation. It's a mine! An old mine!" Entrapta said.

"And it's recently been visited," Sam added.

"So… it looks like the Russians are playing their old games again," the Colonel said, shaking his head.

"You think this is run by the Russian government?" Glimmer asked.

"You betcha," the Colonel replied. He bared his teeth. "Let's see if we can foil whatever they are planning. Without blowing up the taiga, of course."

"Of course," Entrapta added, a little too serious for Sam's taste.

"Why would they do this? They were behind the resolution to secure all alien technology not yet secured," Adora said.

"They're Russians." The Colonel shrugged. "Saying one thing and doing another was the norm for them back in the Cold War, and I doubt they changed since then."

"The United States weren't exactly very honourable and trustworthy either," Daniel said with a frown.

“But we didn’t try to hide alien artefacts after telling the UN to secure them,” the Colonel shot back.

“Because we already had them secured,” Daniel retorted.

“It still makes no sense. They know we can detect the Naquadah,” Adora said. “They can’t hide from us.”

“But they can blame it all on a subordinate and say their orders were misunderstood,” the Colonel said.

“Or this could be a splinter group, criminals - or a Goa’uld base,” Daniel said.

The Colonel frowned. “That’s… also possible. Damn, I knew this was too good to be true! I was so looking forward to ruining the Russians’ day.”

“Jack…” Daniel shook his head.

“You weren’t there,” the Colonel replied. “It’s a Cold War thing. Well, let’s find out if we’re going to hunt a Snake or poke the Russian bear.”

Catra snorted. “Sounds fun.”

“Catra!” Adora shook her head. “This could be a diplomatic disaster!”

The catwoman shrugged. “It’s not our fault. We’re honouring the request of the Security Council, aren’t we?”

The Colonel nodded with a matching grin. The two were quite alike in some ways, Sam thought, not for the first time. Though she was also aware that the US government would be happy if the relationship between Russia and the Etherians would become strained over this.

Very happy.

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"...and thank you. Have a nice day."

Catra leaned against the wall next to the door of the bridge, ears twitching, as O'Neill finished the call. Audio only, since for some reason, the Russians didn't want to transmit a picture or something.

O'Neill was smiling widely - like Glimmer when she got one over Catra - as he turned to face the rest of them. "Hah! I knew it! It's a secret government facility!"

"And they admitted it?" Daniel asked.

"We're hovering over its location with a spaceship," O'Neill said. "Not even the Russians would try to bluff that out. Well, most of them wouldn't." He shrugged. "Anyway, we can land next to the entrance - someone's supposed to meet us there. The 'caretaker to this absolutely not functional research station that the government totally forgot about'."

"My Russian is a bit rustier than yours, Jack, but I don't think that's an exact quote," Daniel commented. He sounded a bit jealous, in Catra's impression.

"It's a concise summary of their claims," O'Neill retorted. "Anyway, let's land - but carefully. We don't know what's in there since the Russians claim they don't know either, just that it is a storage site dating back to the Second World War."

Ah. "So there could be a Goa'uld in charge?" Adora asked.

"The Naquadah concentration hasn't moved and is too large for a Goa'uld, according to our scanner," Carter told her. "Although if a Goa'uld was wearing or carrying Naquadah devices, it might match the result we got."

"Great. So, stay sharp, folks! And don't leave the ship unguarded."

“We can take the shuttle down,” Adora suggested. “Who gets to stay on it?”

Since Adora would certainly be going down, Catra would be going down as well, so she didn’t even twitch at the question. By now, people should know better than to try and separate them. And Melog would likely tag along anyway - it was almost impossible to keep them out of something they wanted to enter.

Entrapta looked torn. “Someone who can use the scanner should stay… But I really want to see the technology down there! Maybe they have other, non-Naquadah-based technology?”

“Well, Russian technology of the time was said to be so durable, it would keep running even if Russians maintained it,” O’Neill said with a chuckle. “But I don’t think it’ll be impressive.”

Catra glanced at Carter. The scientist was fiddling with a gadget - it was obvious that she wanted to go down into the mine as well.

“I will stay on the ship,” Hordak said. “I can operate both the weapons and the scanner, should you need assistance.”

“Oh, thank you!” Entrapta went to hug him. “We’ll bring back the most interesting piece of technology we find!” She blinked. “If we’re allowed to, of course.”

“Let’s stick to alien technology,” O’Neill said. “That way, the Russians can’t really complain. I mean - they forgot about alien technology? Hah!”

“Well, it’s possible,” Bow said. “We once forgot…”

“Yes, it’s possible,” Glimmer cut in with a frown at him. “But we should go now.”

Catra smirked as they walked to the shuttle - she had to get that story from Bow once they weren’t rushing to secure Naquadah any more.

It took them longer to board the shuttle and fly out of Darla's hold than to land the thing, and by the time they disembarked - after checking for ambushes - the side of the hill in front of them was parting, revealing camouflaged doors. As soon as they opened, a slightly out of breath man the size of, well, almost Scorpia, greeted them with a funny accent. "Hello, Etherians and Americans! Welcome to Siberia! I am Dr Iwan Georgovich, sent here to take inventory of storage site!"

Behind him, four soldiers who didn't look out of breath appeared. Catra kept an eye on them.

"Hello. I'm Colonel Jack O'Neill, Stargate Command, and these are…"

"Oh, but we know them! Of them!" Georgovich beamed. "The aliens who came to visit Earth and protect us! Magical Princesses from Outer Space! You must have so much knowledge! And stories!"

"Oh great," Catra heard O'Neill mutter. "We've got a royalist Russian."

"Yeah, that's us," Adora said, smiling back. "And we'd love to talk about it. But we need to secure an alien artefact first."

"Wouldn't want to see this part of the planet blown up," O'Neill added.

"Oh, of course not, of course not! And you are in luck - we already secured the artefact - without touching it, mind you! Come in, come in! It's just a short drive!"

"A drive?" Adora asked.

"Da! Long tunnel, for safety reasons - back when Cold War might go hot - so we drive!"

In an Earth vehicle that looked a few decades old, according to the movies they had seen. And it ran on rails. If they ended up

jumping tracks in an old abandoned mine, Catra would claw someone.

"So," the big man went on as they got into the car-thing, "this site was made after Great Patriotic War - Second World War - to store all the technology secured from the Nazis."

"The Nazis? Don't tell me that Hitler was a snake!" O'Neill blurted out.

"We do not think so," the man replied. "But we cannot tell. But if he was, wouldn't he have won the war with alien technology?"

"Not necessarily," Daniel said. "He might have been afraid to catch Ra's attention, and so he would…"

"It was a joke, Daniel," O'Neill said.

"Oh."

The Russian laughed. "Hah! Anyway, we take fascist technology and sort it out. Pieces left over are stored here, to be sorted out later. But later never comes, so we forgot. But we're back now, and cataloguing everything!"

"We're close to the concentration now, Sir," Carter said as the car came to a stop.

"Right, we brought crate here."

And there was a wooden crate sitting on what looked like a small loading dock. An open crate, with a…

"A DHD!" O'Neill blurted out. "We've been looking for one for ages, and there's one here? On Earth? You've had it for decades after you took it from the Nazis?"

The big Russian smiled. "Da! Good thing, yes?"

Catra chuckled at O'Neill's expression.

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The Naquadah Crisis Part 7

North of Bratsk, Russia, Earth, Solar System, August 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

A DHD. On Earth. Stargate Command had had to build a supercomputer to operate the gate and deal with all the bugs that popped up until it worked, and the Russians had a DHD stored in some bunker since World War II! Even worse, the Russians hadn't even known about it!

Jack O'Neill barely managed not to snarl at the far too happy scientist.

"So, this is a nice piece of alien technology, da? You know what it does, right?" Dr Georgovich prattled on. "The symbols, they look like on the gate, da?"

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta nodded. "This is a DHD. It's used to operate a stargate. Well, you can use a Stargate without it, but you need to emulate this, and that takes a lot of computing power. Although if we can analyse this, we should be able to streamline the process. Probably - science doesn't always produce the results you want, after all." Her hair flew over the DHD, not moving the dials, but almost caressing it.

"Ah, the key to Stargate. Very important. Good thing Russia secured it before the Nazis could use it." Georgovich nodded. He seemed a little distracted by the hair tendrils.

"You looted it after the Nazis were beaten," Jack corrected him.

"Defeated by glorious Red Army, yes. Before Nazis could use alien technology."

"I remember some other countries fighting the Nazis as well. And delivering lots of supplies to the Red Army," Jack retorted.

“Da! Good example of spirit of international cooperation against tyranny, yes?” Georgovich was beaming at him. “Nazis back then, Goa’uld now!”

Jack narrowed his eyes at the Russian. He was sure that the smiling bastard spoke much better English and was not half as simple as he acted. “It’s that how you want to play it?”

“Play? Is no game. Very serious situation. All of Earth needs work together to beat evil space aliens, da? Russia offers secured alien technology for alliance!”

So that was their game.

“Great!” Adora, of course, was eating it up. “So, can we take the DHD off your hands?”

“Da! Russia hands over the alien technology to United Nations and Magical Princess Alliance! In the spirit of international cooperation!”

“Like the Security Council ordered,” Jack pointed out. “We were tasked with securing this.”

“Security Council ordered all unsecured alien technology to be secured. This technology was secured. Very secured in secret bunker. This is Russia’s contribution to alliance against Goa’uld. First contribution.”

“And you can make this decision for Russia?” Jack asked.

“Oh, no! Decision was taken by Russian government in spirit of international cooperation. I merely execute it.” Gregorovich smiled at Jack. “We all should cooperate like this.”

“Yeah, right.” Hand over all alien technology to the United Nations? This was a DHD, but Stargate Command didn’t really need one. They had built a work-around, and they had a lot more knowledge and technology than a single piece of technology that was useless without a gate. Knowledge and technology Stargate

command had often paid dearly for. There was no way they would just hand over everything so the Russians and the others could take over and profit. Next, they would want them to sing The Internationale every morning or something.

But again, the Etherians seemed fooled. Adora beamed at the far too jovial Russian, and Glimmer nodded in apparent approval. At least Catra wasn't fooled - though Jack gave it even odds that she found this amusing.

"So, let's get this on the ship then," Adora said. "Is there any either alien technology stored here?"

"Nothing using Naquadah," Entrapta said, looking up from her scanner thingie. "But there might be more advanced technology. Or interesting Earth technology."

"Is that the alien scanner?" Gregorovich leaned forward and craned his neck. "You can scan for alien metal with it?"

"Yes! Well, it's a remote control for the scanner in Darla," Entrapta explained.

"Ah! How does it work?" The man's grasp on English improved when he was asking such questions, Jack noted.

"It uses the law of similarity for Naquadah," Entrapta said. "That's a basic law of magic."

"Magic?" Gregorovich pulled back a little. "This is magic? Not technology?"

"It's basically the same," Entrapta, apparently not having noticed his reaction, explained. "It just uses different principles, and in order to use a nonmagical power source, you have to have a converter. And you also need to apply First Ones technology so you can scan on a planet - or in space - where there is no magic field. So, it's a bit more complicated than a standard magical scanner but much more useful in various environments."

"Ah! And what's its range?"

"Well… it covers the whole planet? But mostly for a generic scan; more detailed information needs closer attention, and sometimes recalibration."

"It's a complicated procedure that requires extensive experience," Carter added.

"Ah." Gregorovich smiled again. "But anyone can do it, da?"

"In theory, yes, but you'd need to understand both magic and First One - or ancient - technology. Although Goa'uld technology might be enough as well," Entrapta said.

"Ah." And that damned smile widened. "I am looking forward to more cooperation. In science!"

"Great!" Entrapta beamed at him.

"Just don't blow up the planet by accident," Jack commented.

"I wouldn't!" Entrapta protested. "That only almost happened because of special circumstances which are very unlikely to be reproducible on Earth."

Seeing the Russian's smile vanish was very satisfying for Jack.

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Adora was happy that at least one country wasn't trying to be obstructive. And the Russians weren't even forced to cooperate by a zombie plague or a bomb threat. They just handed over the DHD 'in the spirit of international cooperation'. She smiled as she hefted the crate containing the device and carried it to the waiting transport vehicle.

"Very strong indeed!" the Russian, Iwan, commented.

Adora smiled. "I'm the Princess of Power."

“She lifts, she digs, she carries,” Catra added.

Adora frowned at her lover - that hadn’t sounded like an honest compliment.

“So, this is important contribution, da?”

“It’s great! We can examine it and copy it - I think. At the very least, we can copy the communication protocols,” Entrapta said.

“The DHD also provides the Stargate with power,” Sam added. “It must have an incredible power generation method to provide power for millions of years.”

“Or huge batteries?” Jack speculated with a grin.

“Batteries run out,” Iwan said. “But generator can explode. If this breaks, and all the energy set free…”

Adora didn’t freeze. But she was a little more careful with her cargo. Just in case.

“Well, I don’t think we should do destructive testing until we can duplicate the device in its entirety,” Entrapta said. “But if the power contained inside it - unless it’s just a conduit - were released by an explosion… Hm… I have to calculate if it would destroy the planet or merely cause enough destruction to wreck the biosphere.”

Yes, she had to be very careful.

“How about we take it to space as well?” Jack suggested.

“We haven’t heard of any such explosion, Sir,” Sam retorted. “And none of the Jaffa showed any reluctance to use weapons near or at the DHD on our missions. So, I would assume that they are very hard to set off - if that’s even possible. If the power is syphoned off from the source - like another dimension - then destroying the device would merely interrupt the power, not set it off.”

“That would make more sense,” Daniel said.

“Well, the Ancients didn’t strike me as people with a lot of common sense, at least as we see it,” Jack said.

“True,” Daniel said.

“But they were geniuses! Their technology is still beyond us!” Entrapta protested.

“Yes, but they had a rather tenuous relationship with safety procedures and fail-safes,” Jack retorted.

Adora put the crate down and pushed the memory of the First Ones fail-safe away.

“Yeah, maybe we should be a bit more careful when following their footsteps,” Glimmer said.

“But the Stargates are safe and easy to use!”

“Ah…” Jack grimaced.

“We are using a Stargate with a control device of our own design, Sir,” Sam said. “That might cause some issues - which I hope we can remove now that we can study a DHD.”

“Yeah, I bet we would have voided our warranty for using non-factory parts.” Jack grinned, and the others laughed. Adora joined in, even though she didn’t quite get the joke.

“Before we move the DHD away from Earth, we should check with the Security Council,” Glimmer said. “This is all under their authority, after all.”

“Da!” Iwan nodded. “And we share scientific knowledge, right?”

“I would think so,” Glimmer said.

“Why not? It was yours, right?”

“Because it might contain enough power to blow up Earth if it gets some Russian percussive maintenance?” Jack bared his teeth.

Iwan laughed. “Very funny, Colonel O’Neill. Dark humour - very Russian.”

That didn’t please Jack, Adora saw.

“Or British?” Daniel added. “They have a reputation for black humour.”

“Well, the DHD is secured on the transport now - let’s get it to the ship?”

“But we need to check the rest of the mine for more technology!” Entrapta said. “Who knows what else might have been forgotten inside here?”

“Our mandate only covers the alien technology,” Glimmer told her.

“There could be alien technology that doesn’t use Naquadah,” Entrapta said.

“And it could be as dangerous - like magic,” Jack added. “Better take a closer look, right? And I’m sure the Security Council didn’t want us limited to Naquadah.”

“Da,” Iwan agreed, although a little less enthusiastic.

“Let’s go!” Entrapta dashed away, carried by her hair, striding past the other soldiers present.

“Very enthusiastic scientist, yes?”

“Yeah, that’s Entrapta for you,” Catra said. “Now, let’s go help her sort through your stuff.”

Adora looked at the crate. They couldn’t leave it unguarded here. “I’ll take it back to the shuttle, then I’ll join you.”

She took the transport back to the entrance, with another soldier operating it, and easily but carefully carried the device inside. By the time she was back in the mine, Entrapta and Sam had already gone through one storage area and were starting on the next.

"So far, it's just been ugly art and some primitive tech," Catra, leaning against the wall, told her.

"Nazi technology and stolen art," Jack corrected her.

"As I said."

"Some of those artworks were thought lost!" Daniel protested.

"Oh?" Adora blinked. "More ancient treasures looted by your Empires?"

"Ah…" Jack trailed off.

"You could say that, yes," Daniel said.

"Shouldn't that be returned to the original owners then?"

"Ah… it complicated," Iwan said. His smile looked rather thin.

*****

Naval Station Norfolk, United States of America, Earth, August 21st, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter felt slightly guilty as she looked down at the base. She'd just slept almost ten hours, even though they still had to secure the concentration of Naquadah under the sea off the US East Coast. Of course, she had needed the sleep - almost as much as the Colonel and Daniel - and she knew taking care of yourself was crucial for fulfilling your duty; exhaustion, both mental and physical, led to mistakes. And you couldn't afford mistakes when dealing with Goa'uld.

But she could have studied the recovered artefacts. Recalibrated the scanner. Written a better report about the DHD they had recovered from the Russians - one that might be given greater weight when the government made its decision about how to handle the 'Russians' game', as the Colonel put it. Especially since the DHD was still in the ship's hold.

"So… that's the submarine?" Bow asked next to her, peering down at the Los Angeles Class vessel moored next to a pier.

"That's a submarine," she corrected him. "But it won't do the actual recovery. That will be done by a specialist vessel." She pointed at the USNS Salvor on the other side of the base. "It's a specialised rescue and salvage ship. They have divers and specialised mini-submarines for missions such as this. The submarine here will provide additional security." They already had one sub in place over the wreck that contains the Naquadah and two more patrolling the approaches - the Colonel wasn't the only one who suspected that the Russians wouldn't mind pulling something underhanded.

"Ah." Bow smiled. "Entrapta will be disappointed if she doesn't get to board a submarine."

Sam nodded - she was well aware of that fact. And, speaking of the princess… "Where is she?"

"Still asleep," Bow replied with a slight shrug. "She stayed up longer than you, and when Catra switched her concentrated tiny tea for flavoured water, she fell asleep in the lab. Hordak carried her to bed."

"Ah." She looked around. They were alone on the bridge.

"Most are still asleep as well," he said, smiling - he looked well-rested. "Glimmer's preparing her next speech - but don't tell her I told you. And Adora and Catra are…" He shrugged, blushing slightly.

Sam nodded again. She could imagine very well what the two were up to or had been up to. Catra had never tried to hide it - quite the contrary. The Etherians didn't have any regulations against fraternisation within the same chain of command, after all.

She suppressed the pang of envy. The regulations made a lot of sense. You were never as professional as you thought you would be. And even if you could handle such a relationship, others wouldn't, and personal exemptions would only cause more friction and resentment.

That didn't mean she had to like it, of course.

Bow must have misinterpreted her short silence since he smiled apologetically. "You could say they have a lot of wasted opportunities to make up for."

She was aware of that, if not of the details. But you didn't have to be a genius to figure out that two people on different sides of a war couldn't be together, so she nodded. Besides, it was the Etherians' custom, none of her business.

"Of course, what with the 'unnatural relationship' complaints from your country, Catra might also want to be more blatant about it," Bow added.

Sam blinked. "What complaints?"

"Oh, not official ones. Just some tv show or something." Bow made a dismissive wave with his hand. "We know it's not representative of your country. As Glimmer said, every country has a bunch of idiots." Before Sam could inquire what exactly they had seen - she certainly hadn't had any time to watch TV - he went on: "We're more concerned about the people who blame us for the explosion in Egypt."

Sam suppressed a groan. Of course some would blame this on the Etherians. The Egyptian army and its government would probably not mind if they were cleared of any blame. "Any investigation will

show that this wasn't your fault. You weren't there when it happened."

"Well, one of the arguments used is that without our arrival, none of this would have happened." He shrugged. "It might be true, even - without our warnings, the Egyptians might not have investigated the temples."

"We don't know what caused the explosion," she pointed out.

"Yes." He shrugged. "Anyway, let's hope this operation goes off like the last one." He smiled again. "I mean, without an explosion or zombies. Glimmer's aware of the political implications."

Sam nodded. She wasn't certain whether or not Glimmer caught all the nuances - or if anyone, Russian or American, did - but it was a good reminder that while the Etherians might appear naive and idealistic, they were also - at least Glimmer and Catra - pragmatic and had experience with politics. Something Sam feared not all members of her own government, much less Congress, might realise. "Well, we should focus on recovering the Naquadah here," she said.

"Yes. At least to what degree we can, without being directly involved," he agreed. "Staying back and watching while others risk their lives…"

"Adora's not going to like it," Sam said.

He chuckled at that. "I think that half the reason Catra's teasing her about being a nice multipurpose tool is to make her realise that she doesn't have to do everything herself."

That made sense. "And the other half?"

"Because she likes teasing Adora."

"Ah." That made sense as well, of course.

They stared down at the base in silence for a moment before Glimmer stepped on the bridge, complaining about their schedule.

*****

Off the East Coast, Atlantic, Earth, August 21st, 1998 (Earth Time)

"We should have stayed on Darla," Catra said, glancing at the railing. "We can react much quicker to anything up there, and we have better sensors to spot trouble. And more firepower to deal with it. This ship is rather flimsy - it doesn't even have shields and barely any weapons." And there was an ocean below them, full of deep, cold water…

"You could've stayed on Darla if you wanted," Glimmer commented. With a grin, she added: "Where you are safe from the big, bad, evil water."

Catra glared at her, but Glimmer giggled in return.

And, worse, O'Neill picked it up. "What? Don't tell me you're afraid of water! Like a housecat!"

She narrowed her eyes at the man, but Daniel piped up before she could come up with a good comeback. "Actually, there are housecats that love swimming in water."

"I'm not afraid of water," Catra snapped. "I just don't like the thought of swimming in this… this sea here, with some unknown Naquadah devices on the seabed that could turn me into a zombie!" There! A perfectly valid reason not to want to go swimming. "And salt water is hell on my fur," she added.

"It's true - it makes her fur all crusty and salty." Adora nodded. "And then we have to spend an hour in the bath to get her clean."

"Well, let's hope that you didn't frighten off our brave Navy divers," O'Neill said with a stupid smirk and a glance at the two people pulling on diving suits and stuff a bit away from them.

“I doubt they heard me over all the noise on this ship,” Catra shot back. “And don’t tell me that you’d send them down there without telling them the risks?”

“We wouldn’t,” Daniel said. “They are volunteers.”

“Real volunteers?” Catra raised her eyebrows - she knew how that had worked in the Horde.

“Yes, real volunteers,” O’Neill replied with a frown. “Some people are like that.”

“Not very smart then,” Catra said. “Let’s hope they’re smart enough to handle the artefacts without blowing us all up.”

“Well, they’re Navy, so they weren’t smart enough to get into the Air Force, but since they survived doing dangerous diving missions, I think they should do.” O’Neill nodded.

“Jack!”

“Daniel, ribbing the rival services is a centuries-old tradition. Not doing it is supposed to bring bad luck,” O’Neil claimed.

“What the…? Oh, for… Sam! I’ve got a question!” Daniel went on towards the aft of the ship, where Entrapta and Carter had set up.

“That wasn’t very nice,” Adora said. Of course she meant Daniel getting ribbed, not Catra. Catra frowned at her, and she smiled. “You can take it, Catra. Besides, you do hate water.”

Catra narrowed her eyes for a moment. This was… ah! She smiled - saucily. “Oh, I like it when it’s hot and soapy, and we’re washing each other’s back, and you make those cute noises when I…”

“Catra!” Adora hissed, blushing crazily.

Catra snorted in return. As if Adora could beat her at teasing!

O’Neill cleared his throat. “Very informative.”

Catra eyed him. He put up a good front, but she was sure that the man was jealous. Or at least didn't like the teasing.

Daniel returned, glaring at O'Neill but not saying anything. O'Neill grinned.

"I believe they are now ready to start the operation," Teal'c commented - he hadn't shown any reaction to the whole scene, not that Catra had expected him. The big man was more stoic than a stone statue. Most of the time. But she wondered what would happen if he ever lost his temper.

And he was right - the divers were now mounting what looked like some underwater vehicle. Or a bot with seats. And some Navy officer was walking over to the group. "Do you wish to follow the operation from the bridge?"

"Naw, we're good here," O'Neill replied before anyone else could say anything. "I bet we have the better view from here."

The officer frowned for a moment before nodding. "As you wish, Colonel."

"Carter and Entrapta probably can see more from orbit than the Navy can see in front of their eyes," O'Neill said as the man left.

"You really take this ribbing seriously, do you?"

"It's a…"

Daniel cut him off with a frown. "He likes to needle others."

"Keeps them on their toes," O'Neill grinned again. "Let's see how the operation is going."

It seemed to be a straightforward operation, in Catra's opinion. Go down, grab the stuff - with Entrapta and Carter directing the divers, if needed - and bring it up. And it did start that way, even though it took the divers longer than she had expected tor each the wreck.

“Looks like an old tramp freighter,” O’Neill commented.

“We already knew that,” Daniel told him. “We actually identified it as the ‘Esmeralda’, a ship chartered by the Steward expedition to Egypt in 1930.”

“I know.”

“And you didn’t track it down after you knew about the Stargate?” Catra asked.

“We had no idea where it had sunk,” Daniel told her. “I actually recommended checking out every Egyptian relic in public and private collections, but we didn’t get around to do it yet.”

“Daniel wanted to do some sightseeing on Uncle Sam’s dime,” O’Neill said.

“Jack!”

“What?”

“Oh!” Entrapta piped up. “Look, they found something!”

Something alright - in the cone of the diver’s flashlight, Catra could see what looked like busts.

“That’s a depiction of…” Daniel squinted. “...Osiris. And Isis.”

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“Osiris and Isis. And that means?” Jack O`Neill asked, cocking his head to the side. Daniel was a great friend and great archaeologist, but he usually needed a bit of prodding and poking to get to the point.

“Osiris was the god of fertility, agriculture, the afterlife, the dead and resurrection. According to legend, his brother Set cut him into pieces, and his wife, Isis, gathered the pieces and put him together again, resurrecting him,” Daniel explained… nothing.

“Talk about marital devotion,” Jack joked. “So, was that a power struggle amongst the Goa’uld?”

“I don’t know. We’d have to ask our captive from Seattle once we find a way to communicate with it,” Daniel replied. “And this one, if this contains Osiris and Isis… This could shed so much light on the earliest period of Goa’uld rule!”

Jack raised his eyebrows. “So, these are stasis pods containing two ancient Goa’ulds?”

“Osiris and Isis have been missing since before Ra’s retreat from Earth,” Teal’c commented. “Which would support that these pods contain them.”

“Great. Two more snakes for our collection.” Jack grinned. Too bad that the snakes’ intel would be outdated, but they were talking about Goa’uld - they carried grudges for millennia, so there might be something actionable to gain from this. But they had to be careful. “Tell the divers to proceed with extreme caution. We don’t want those things to break.” The last thing they needed was a snaked sailor. Though… “Can snakes survive at that depth?”

“I don’t think the pressure would be too harmful, but the lack of oxygen and the sudden shock from their stasis pod breaking would likely be fatal,” Carter replied.

“Indeed,” Teal’c confirmed it.

“Well, that’s good news,” Jack said. He wouldn’t shed a tear if the pod broke and a snake died before it could take over people.

But the divers knew their stuff - well, they should; the Navy knew how important this was - and recovered the two things without breaking them. That was one advantage at least of having to reveal the Stargate project: They could tell the rest of the armed forces the truth about their missions. And while Jack wouldn’t admit it, ever, no longer having to claim that they were doing Deep Space telemetry was very nice as well. He wouldn’t miss the

pitying glances from other officers who thought he was a wash-out or screw-up in a dead-end assignment.

"So, anything else down there?" he asked when the pods had been secured.

"Well… there are a few more things according to our scanner," Entrapta said. "Not quite as large, but still looks to be refined Naquadah."

Which turned out to be a zat'nik'tel and a… thingie.

"Oh! That's new! We haven't seen this before!" Entrapta squealed. "I can't wait to find out what it does!"

Jack was about to caution her about being cautious when Teal'c spoke up again: "That is a scales cleaner."

"A what?" Jack asked.

"When a Goa'uld outside a host needs their scales cleaned, they can slip into this device, and gentle pressure from the muzzles inside will clean their scales as they pass through the tube," Teal'c explained.

"It's a snake washing machine." Jack chuckled. "Now I've seen everything."

"Aw! That doesn't sound particularly interesting." Entrapta pouted.

Daniel, though, was intrigued. "It's fascinating. In order to use this, a Goa'uld had to leave a host. So, was this reserved for special occasions? Or did they regularly leave a host - temporarily - to do this? Do they have to clean their scales for a biological reason, or is this merely a convenience? Or a cultural ritual, like a symbolic shedding of an old skin?"

Jack stared at him. Those were… very Daniel questions. Although… "So… if they leave a host for this machine, we could trap those and kill a Goa'uld without hurting the host?"

Daniel's eyes lit up. "Sharee…" he whispered.

Jack clenched his teeth. He shouldn't have speculated like this. They had no idea how to get to Daniel's wife, much less do so without being detected and then wait for such an occasion for who knew how long. Giving his friend false hope…

"We'll save her!" Adora said, nodding firmly. "No matter where she is, we'll save her!"

Jack usually would make a sarcastic remark, but… Daniel looked so hopeful, and Adora looked so determined, he couldn't make himself do it.

And as much as he knew it was wrong, he couldn't help feeling hopeful himself.

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Adora nodded with a smile. They would help Daniel save his wife. That was what She-Ra did - help those in need. Protect and save people.

Though they would have to find her, first. And in order to do that, they would have to be ready for war - and that meant making an alliance with Earth. Or at least with some countries on Earth.

"They're coming up again!" Entrapta said. "Or not."

"They need to take it slow so they won't get the bends," Sam explained.

"Ah. Shouldn't the diving suits do that for them?" Entrapta blinked. "That seems like an obvious feature."

"These diving suits aren't as advanced as the ones you are thinking of," Sam told her.

"Why are they using them, then?"

“They allow more flexibility underwater at those depths.”

“Oh. We should have constructed better suits then!”

“That would have taken too long,” Sam said.

“Well, we can add it to the list!” Entrapta nodded.

“No, you wouldn’t have been able to do it faster,” Catra said behind Adora.

“I wasn’t thinking about that,” Adora retorted with a pout. But now that Catra had mentioned it…

“You’re not invulnerable,” Catra insisted.

She knew that. And she refrained from rubbing her back, where she still had some faint scars from Catra’s claws. “Anyway, that’s the last Naquadah that wasn’t accounted for,” Adora said. “That means that Earth is safe again.”

“Safer,” Jack corrected her. “I wouldn’t say we’re safe.”

“You’ve got too many idiots on the planet for that,” Catra agreed.

Adora shook her head. “The planet is safer, then.” She scoffed. “You need to stop being such…” She frowned. What was the best word?

“Downers,” Bow said. “Always seeing gloom and doom.” He smiled. “We did well.”

“We haven’t secured the pods yet,” Catra pointed out.

“If anything happens now, Adora can jump in and grab them.”

She nodded. She could do that - she had fought a sea monster before she had really understood her power. Powers.

Catra scoffed, as she usually did when she lost an argument. “Yeah, yeah. Anyway, after this, it’s back to negotiations.”

Right. Negotiations with stubborn and weird people. And stupid people.

Not even Bow had a good answer to that.

And before Adora could come up with a comeback, the divers reached the surface, and everyone rushed to take the pods and the other things.

“Put the busts into the containment unit!” Sam ordered them as Entrapta put the container down next to the still dripping underwater vehicle - it wasn’t a submarine; Adora had asked.

“Wait!” Daniel held his hand up and knelt down next to the female bust. Pod. Thing. “This…”

“Watch out, Daniel! You’re not snake-poof!” Jack moved, and Adora thought he’d pull Daniel back, but the man only knelt down next to his friend.

“The seal!” Daniel said. “It’s broken!”

“What?” Adora tensed, and she saw Catra look around. “We need the Scanners!”

“There’s no Naquadah nearby - except for the pods, the zat’nik’tel and the tool,” Sam told them a moment later.

“Yes,” Daniel said. “I think the seal broke long ago. And the Goa’uld is still inside.”

“Oh.” Adora blinked as Daniel reached out and opened the pod before anyone could stop him.

But the Goa’uld inside looked very dead.

“Well, I guess Osiris isn’t coming back from death this time,” Jack said.

“That’s actually Isis, Jack,” Daniel said. “Unless they mixed up the busts when they put them into stasis.”

“Well, we could attempt to revive them using the other device,” Entrapta suggested.

“Yeah, let’s create a zombie snake. That’s what I was missing my life,” Jack said.

Entrapta looked at him for a moment. “Really? If you had said something earlier, we could have gotten you a zombified snake from Honduras.”

Jack stared at her.

“Ah, you were joking.” Entrapta nodded. “Anyway, usually, the brain would be wiped clean, so it would just be a mindless creature, but since they have a genetic memory, it might actually restore them with their genetic memory,” she said. “If it works. Which isn’t certain - we don’t know yet how exactly it works, and we also don’t know enough about Goa’uld biology to tell.” She perked up. “But we could find out!”

“Ah…” Jack grimaced. “I think we should focus on other areas of research first.”

“Like the DHD,” Sam suggested. “And the alien data core.”

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. “We’ve got so much science to do!”

Well, at least she was happy. Adora smiled.

“And we have another Goa’uld to interrogate. Or not to interrogate, as things are.”

Entrapta frowned again. “Oh. We could use the zombies as hosts, couldn’t we?” They already are dead and just going on, so… it might just work?” She smiled.

Adora wasn't the only one who grimaced. "Uh…"

"That sounds… morbid," Daniel said.

"Would it even work if the body's actually dead and just the individual cells are kept alive?" Sam asked.

"Worth a try?" Entrapta asked. "Although we might have to hurry because the human bodies probably aren't lasting much longer because the cells will soonish run out of energy."

"I don't think we should use zombie hosts," Jack said. "That never ends well in the movies."

"And we don't know what it would do to a Goa'uld. It could hurt them - then that would be torture of prisoners," Daniel pointed out.

"Oh." Entrapta slowly nodded. "That would be bad."

"Yes," Adora agreed.

"So, plenty of reasons not to risk a zombie Goa'uld escaping," Catra said.

"Oh, we would do it in space, so they wouldn't be able to escape. Unless zombies could survive the vacuum and reentry, or they had help, I guess," Entrapta said.

"Which we shouldn't test," Sam said.

"Well, it would count as a space burial?" Jack asked.

It was probably meant as a joke, but Adora didn't think it was funny. Even though Catra snorted.

Really, her lover's sense of humour was sometimes a bit too dark for Adora's taste.

*****

Above the Atlantic, Earth, August 21st, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So… Do you think that using a zombie body as a host would work? Hypothetically, I mean."

Samantha Carter stiffened for a moment when she heard Entrapta's question. Then she put the scale cleaning tool she had been examining in Darla's hold down and turned to face the princess. "We don't know enough about the workings of that ancient device. And we don't know enough about the way Goa'uld possession works."

"That would seem to be a compelling reason to research the matter thoroughly," Hordak commented.

"Yes." Entrapta nodded. "The data would be very useful, wouldn't it? We will probably get other prisoners. We already have two and would have had a third if the stasis pod hadn't have failed."

The pure scientist in Sam agreed, of course. If they wanted to be able to free hosts from the Goa'uld controlling their bodies, they needed to know exactly how that worked. And to be able to interrogate Goa'uld would be very useful for gathering intelligence. And there was the possibility of coming to an arrangement with selected Goa'uld. Making a treaty would be more palatable for Earth - and for the Etherians - if you didn't have to accept that a human being would be used as a host. Of course, for that, the Goa'uld would have to free their slaves as well, and the odds for that were…

She shook her head. "It's not just about what is useful. There are moral aspects to consider. Important aspects."

She wasn't an expert on alien expressions, but Hordak looked like she had said some gibberish. And Entrapta looked confused. "But we already know that the zombies are dead - just a collection of individual cells without a higher consciousness left. Where's the moral aspect in using that?"

“Many cultures on Earth consider experimenting on the dead the same as desecrating the dead unless the deceased gave permission,” Sam explained.

“Ah. So, it goes against Earth customs.”

And probably Etherian customs as well - Sam couldn’t see Adora or Glimmer allowing experiments with dead bodies. She could be wrong, but Daniel would have told them if he had found such an important difference between their cultures.

“With six billion people, it shouldn’t be hard to find volunteers who are about to die,” Hordak said.

“But wouldn’t Adora heal them?” Entrapta objected. “She wouldn’t want to let them die if she could heal them, would she?”

And wasn’t that an entirely different can of worms! Sam sighed. “Even if we had animated corpses that we could use for experiments without breaking the law and violating moral principles, there’s also the fact to consider that we don’t know what such a host would do to a Goa’uld. We mentioned that before.” Though Hordak hadn’t heard that discussion.

“They are enemies. Prisoners.” Yes, Hordak definitely hadn’t heard that.

“We do not experiment on prisoners. Or torture them,” Sam told them. “It’s against the law.”

“Is that the law in the United States or one of your few global agreements?” the alien asked.

“It’s international law,” Sam replied, as firmly as she could. “And the Goa’uld being aliens doesn’t change that they are protected as prisoners of war.” She suppressed the sudden urge to add a qualifier about uniformed soldiers and spies. This was about ethics, not lawyering.

"I see. So, we would need the Goa'ulds' agreement to conduct experiments."

That wasn't what Sam had been aiming for, but she couldn't really walk back on that. So she nodded.

"And we can't get that if we can't talk to them. I guess we'll have to build a tiny keyboard for them so they can communicate with us," Entrapta said, smiling.

Well, Sam thought, there shouldn't be an issue with that. "As long as it's completely isolated - no connection to other systems, just a screen to show the text."

"Right. And maybe to each other? Now that we have two prisoners," Entrapta suggested.

"Since, according to our legends, Set was the one who murdered Osiris, we might want to be a bit cautious with that," Sam reminded them.

"Oh. I forgot about that. But wasn't it several thousand years since that? And he obviously got better!"

"Goa'uld carry grudges," Sam said.

"Perhaps related to their genetic memories," Hordak speculated. "And that would mean such grudges spread to others as they give birth to more Goa'uld. The Goa'uld Empire might be even more fragile than we assumed."

"I wouldn't want to be too optimistic," Sam cautioned. "Ra ruled it for millennia, and while he is dead, his example shows that a sufficiently powerful Goa'uld can control the others."

"Then we should take care to strike at the most powerful Goa'uld, to keep the enemy fractured and foster infighting," Hordak said. "Although if we appear to best their strongest with ease, we might also incite the rest to unite out of sheer fear." He looked at Sam. "That happened on Etheria."

Sam wasn’t sure how they went from discussing the ethics of zombie experiments to discussing grand strategy. “I think this is a topic for a strategy session,” she said.

“Yes. We should call the others!” Entrapta said.

That wasn’t what Sam had had in mind. But the princess was already using the intercom. It seemed they would be discussing strategy instead of analysing technology until they returned to Stargate Command.

Well, it was less stressful than trying to explain the finer points of ethics to Hordak and Entrapta.

*****

Television Troubles

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, August 21st, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and Egypt remains in turmoil as the riots following the explosion of what has been declared an ancient alien bomb continue despite brutal oppression by the authorities. According to the latest news, the government is calling for a mobilisation, although numerous experts think this might be counterproductive since…"

"...Honduran government has refused to comment on reports about an incident involving a chemical or biological weapon on its territory, claiming that its armed forces have sealed off a part of a natural reserve for anti-bandit operations. Yet trustworthy sources report that the spaceship of the Etherians has been sighted in Honduran airspace, and…"

"...has called on a 'protest of the faithful' against the Etherians, urging the government to cut all ties with the 'blasphemous aliens trying to tempt the good Christians of this great nation into deadly sin'. The US government has cited that it will not let religious views dictate its policies, yet several members of congress were quoted in…"

"... who has been a member of the Republican caucus since 1980, stated that while he understands the reservations some Christians might have with regards to legalising gay marriage, it wasn't the business of the state to regulate the relationships of consenting adults. 'Marriage is between a couple and God', he said, 'and which god someone follows is a private matter'. Faced with questions about earlier statements of his that condemned gay marriage as a sin against God, he declined to comment, and…"

"...Parliament has been discussing the 'gay marriage bill' proposed by Her Majesties Government, and both Houses are expected to vote on it as soon as possible. The Prime Minister replied to

accusations that he was pushing a controversial policy change merely to secure access to the Etherians' technology with the statement that it was past time to acknowledge the realities of today's society and that the United Kingdom would not be left behind by history…"

"...der Bundeskanzler sprach vor dem Parlament und bekräftigte den Willen der Regierung, ein Gesetz für die Öffnung der Ehe für gleichgeschlechtliche Paare so bald as möglich zu verfassen. Konservative Kreise haben den Gang ans Bundesverfassungsgericht angekündigt um dies zu verhindern, aber führende Rechtsexperten schätzen die Erfolgsaussichten als sehr gering ein. Wie Professor…"

"...did the French president call the numerous protests by conservative Catholics in France 'nuisances who would sacrifice our nation's place amongst the leading countries of the world for their bigoted and extremist beliefs'. He declined to respond to questions whether or not his stance was related to his alleged meeting with representatives of leading French businesses in the aerospace and related fields, and went on…"

"...hat ein Komitee angekündigt, eine Volksinitiative zur Legalisierung der gleichgeschlechtlichen Ehe zu starten. Verschiedene National- und Ständeräte haben eine parlamentarische Initiative mit dem gleichen Ziel angekündigt, während sich der Bundesrat weiterhin zurückhält und…"

"...and we're here, in Washington, where a crowd has gathered to protest the aliens' presence on US soil as an affront against God. The police are struggling to keep them and counter-protesters urging the government to legalise gay marriage and ask the Etherians to return magic to Earth apart, and several police officers have allegedly been hurt in the process, although..."

"...and we have to ask ourselves: What is magic? Is it merely a form of technology that we have yet to discover? Or is something more? Something spiritual? Or even… divine? Those who reject

magic as evil might be rejecting something precious, even essential, that would prove…"

"...imagine a world where your neighbour could look at you and curse you! On a whim, they could destroy your life! A stranger on the street could strike you down with lighting! Do you want to live in such a world? No! Say no to magic! Say no to evil sorcery and…"

"...while the Pope has not yet spoken on the matter, the Vatican has confirmed that the nature of magic is a topic that concerns the Church, and…"

"...more lynchings of supposed witches have been reported all over the world, and Amnesty International has called on the United Nations and every religious leader regardless of their faith to condemn 'the senseless murder of innocents' and..."

"...New York Stock Exchange has suspended all trading after yesterday saw a crash that has come to be known as 'Black Thursday 2.0' due to the theory that automated trading by algorithms turned a volatile trading day into a disaster, and…"

"...Russia denied that the emergency measures the government took to 'preserve the country in a time of war' were aimed at hiding the fact that it was about to default on loans, and claimed…"

"...unions called for government aid for struggling businesses affected by magic and alien technology, and…"

"...armed forces were called in to keep a crowd from storming tombs and temple ruins. The government released a statement that they would do 'everything to prevent the tragedy in Egypt from happening here' and ordered a curfew and…"

"...the police in Geneva and the Swiss Army have cordoned off the Palais des Nations after the authorities received threats against both the United Nations and the aliens currently in talks there…"

Sitting in ‘their’ waiting room in the United Nations building, Catra sighed as she switched channels again. Earth news was, well, not completely depressing, but it came close. She had had happier briefings during the height of one of the Alliance’s offensives when Adora had been kicking Horde butt all over the place.

“Can’t you stay on one channel? I have no idea what any of the speakers actually said!” Glimmer complained.

Catra turned her head to look at her, rolling her eyes. “Earth people are crazy and kill each other over imaginary sorcerers. They lie about what happened with alien technology and claim their gods say we’re evil. And everyone is going crazy.”

“You missed that several countries are changing their laws about same-sex relationships,” Bow added, looking up from his tablet.

“That’s common sense and shouldn’t be mentioned.” Catra shot back with a sniff. “Or do you want a report each time someone doesn’t ram their head into a wall instead of opening a door?”

“This is Earth,” Glimmer said. “You can’t expect common sense.”

Catra laughed with her while Bow frowned. “It’s not that bad,” he protested.

“I’ve spent hours in negotiations with the Security Council,” Glimmer corrected him. “Yes, it’s that bad.”

“But the Russians and the Americans are supporting us now, aren’t they? And the French and British too.”

Glimmer snorted. “Everyone wants to get on our good side - and paint the others as the worst possible choice as an ally.”

That was, at least in Catra’s opinion, exaggerated. Slightly.

Bow frowned. “The NATO alliance doesn’t do that to each other.”

“They do it in a more subtle manner. The French representative informed me how quickly they’ll change their laws - and expressed his regrets that not every NATO country could do the same. You should have seen the glare from the American!” Glimmer shook her head. “And the British representative gave me another invitation to a dinner with their Queen.”

“You could accept,” Catra suggested with a grin. “Queen to queen. She likes tea, I think.”

“It wouldn’t be a bad idea,” Bow said. “Would it? She’s the most important queen on the planet.”

“She doesn’t have any political power,” Glimmer objected, as Catra had known she would. “She would just say what the Prime Minister wants her to say. And yes,” she added when Bow opened his mouth, “I know she’s rich, and that many listen to her, but that’s not the same.” She turned to point at the television screen. “And if I meet with her, those people will scream that I want to impose monarchy on the planet.”

“They’re doing that anyway,” Catra pointed out just to be contrarian. Not that it was wrong.

“Yes.” Glimmer scowled. “But if I meet with the Queen of England, everyone else will expect a meeting as well.”

“And you’ll get more marriage proposals.” Catra grinned widely.

Glimmer scoffed. “So does Adora.”

Catra scowled in return. That was true - some people on Earth had no sense at all. And no shame. Adora was with her! She was taken!

“Uh…” Bow cleared his throat while Glimmer giggled, and Catra glared at him. “What?”

He pointed at her hands. “Claws…”

Oh! She had wrecked the armrests of her chair. For a moment, Catra felt ashamed. Then she snorted. Why should she care about that? It wasn't an expensive chair. She deliberately ran another claw over the fabric, splitting it. "Yes?"

Bow sighed.

Glimmer leaned forward, smiling toothily. "And you got marriage proposals as well, didn't you?"

From weirdos. Catra shrugged as if she didn't care at all. "What can I say? People think I'm attractive."

"They like cats."

"At least they don't want to marry me just for power," Catra shot back.

"If you were a princess, they would!"

Bow cleared his throat again. "Anyway! Leaving offers of questionable morals aside, we are making progress, aren't we?"

Glimmer sighed and nodded. "Slowly, but yes. But the Russians and the Chinese…" She shook her head.

"The Russians have been nothing but friendly," Bow said.

"A bit too friendly," Glimmer said. "I don't trust them."

Catra nodded. Iwan was friendly, but Russia's offer was a bit too perfect for her taste. Spirit of international cooperation or not, every country had some issues that complicated an alliance. That was the same for Earth and Etheria.

"But what can they do to earn our trust?" Bow spread his hands. "They are changing their laws, they have offered all their advanced technology to share, and all they ask for is that everyone cooperates."

"Exactly!" Gimmer nodded. "No hints at special exceptions or advantages. Very suspicious."

Bow rolled his eyes and looked at his tablet.

Catra shook her head as she exchanged a glance with Glimmer. Sometimes, Bow was as naive as Adora. She blinked. Would that make her like Glimmer? She scowled and grabbed the remote for the screen again. "Let's watch more news while Adora is busy helping Entrapta move some stuff."

"...and several civil rights organisations are currently debating whether or not magic is protected by the freedom of religion, as members of various Wiccan organisations as well as representatives of the First Nations claim. So far, no conclusion has been reached, and…"

Mixing magic and Earth religion? Catra sighed and switched channels again.

*****

The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, August 21st, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So, what's the verdict, Doc?" Jack O'Neill asked, trying to sound unconcerned and casual. Just a routine examination, nothing else. No reason to worry about mutations or alien genes turning him into a magical princess.

"You're in peak health, Colonel," Dr Fraser told him, glancing from the notepad in her hands to him and back. "For your age, that is."

"So, I won't need a walker this year, but if I find one on sale, I should buy it for next year?" Jack joked to hide his relief.

She frowned in return. "Puerile jokes aside, your body, particularly your knees, don't show any sign of the kind of accumulated microdamage you had before your contact with Etheria."

“I noticed that,” he said. No pain at all was very noticeable.

“That’s why you asked for this examination.” She shook her head. “Which is a first. How ironic that you asked for a thorough examination because you were ‘feeling too well’.”

Jack kept grinning thanks to his long practice of putting on a happy face. He knew that Fraser knew that he hated medical exams because he could hear the day approaching when she’d pronounce him medically unfit for the field. He could feel it in his bones every time he got up in the morning. Well, he had - things had changed after Adora had healed him.

“And I have to note that you didn’t report this right away,” she went on with a deeper frown.

He shrugged. “I wasn’t aware that feeling well was a medical condition I had to report. I’ll be sure to pass it on to the rest of Stargate Command.”

This time, she rolled her eyes. “You know what I mean, Colonel. This examination should have happened at the first opportunity after your return.”

“We were examined,” he pointed out. “You handled it personally.”

“I focused on the usual - signs of being controlled by a Goa’uld, genetic tampering, foreign substances - and not magical healing of the accumulated damage a life as a soldier causes.”

“It was in the report.” Not very prominent - he kinda, sorta had glossed over it - and not with many details, but it had been there.

“A classified report I couldn’t read,” she shot back.

That made him frown. “You should have access to all our medical records.”

“‘Should’, yes. Apparently, someone classified all mentionings of ‘magic’ as above my clearance.” That was a scowl now.

“That wasn’t me,” he protested.

“I’m aware of that, Colonel.” She sighed. “I will have to examine your entire team. And your latest recruit. This is likely related to the… treatment you received from Adora, but it could also be related to this ‘healing device’.”

“The zombie cube,” he corrected her.

She ignored that. “Odds are it isn’t, but we have to be sure.”

“I’ll pass it on,” he said. “But Burke will take some time to arrive here.” Provided he was vetted by Stargate Command. And released by the CIA.

She didn’t like that either. Fraser was a great doctor, but she had a tendency to treat everything related to the medical aspects of Stargate Command as her kingdom and didn’t like it when other concerns - perfectly valid operational concerns! - took precedence. “Send your team to me, Colonel.”

“What about the Hondurans?” he asked.

“If I find anything amiss with your team, we’ll have to look into examining them.”

Good luck with that, he thought. “Will do!” He rose, nodded at her and left the med bay.

“So… at this time of the day, Daniel and Carter will be… in their labs.” He nodded.

*****

Jack O’Neill found Daniel in his lab, surrounded by dusty stones, and staring at his computer. “Hey, Danny-boy! Change of orders!”

“What? Jack!” Daniel looked vaguely offended at Jack interrupting him. “I’m writing my report on the recovery mission!”

Jack made a mental note to get a copy of it. It would make writing his own report easier. “Yeah, drop it for now and report to medical. Fraser’s orders.”

“What? She already examined us.”

“That was the usual check to see if you were a snake in disguise or about to turn into a monster. But she wants a thorough examination to check if we got hit with anything related to zombies.” Technically true.

Daniel grimaced. “Oh. I guess that’s a good idea, even though Sam and Entrapa scanned us already, and we never were in range of the unshielded device.”

“Exactly.” Jack shrugged. “You know how things are with the Doc - what she didn’t personally check isn’t reliable in her opinion.”

Daniel nodded. “I guess I’ll report to her then. Get it over with.” He did look a little concerned, Jack noted.

Well, that couldn’t be helped.

“I’ll inform the others,” Jack told him.

“See you there.”

“I already got examined.”

Daniel blinked, then turned to stare at him. “You did?”

“Yes.” Jack turned. Carter would be in her lab or the control room of the Stargate. The lab, he guessed.

“Jack! What’s going on?”

“Nothing. Just a routine check.”

“Jack!”

Jack hesitated for a moment. “It’s really just a routine check.”

“Really?”

“Yes.” Technically, such examinations were routine after such a mission.

Daniel, though, frowned. “And they examined you before informing us?”

“Yes.” Jack nodded and made shooing motions with his hands. “Now go get prodded and poked! I suffered through it already.”

Daniel still looked suspicious but nodded.

That left Carter.

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, August 21st, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora should have stayed with Entrapta, just in case her friend needed another piece of heavy machinery moved around. Or a bot. Or some tiny tea brewed. Anything would have been better than attending another meeting with the Security Council. She was getting flashbacks to the Princess Prom - and not the good ones about dancing with Catra. The bad ones, where she discovered that for all the hours spent on preparing, she still hadn’t gotten a grip on princess politics because they weren’t acting rationally at all.

“...and, therefore, we suggest creating an international agency to oversee the Stargate Program and take control of the Stargate. With the DHD graciously donated by Russia under control of the agency.”

Oh. The Russian had finished. Adora smiled at him and hoped it didn’t look forced. Hadn’t they suggested such an agency before?

And the American representative started speaking. “While the United States embraces the spirit of international cooperation…”

Adora could hear the sarcasm this time. "...we cannot forget that we are at war with the Goa'uld. This is no time to sacrifice our hard-earned experience and cripple our war efforts for symbolic gestures. The Stargate Program might not be perfect - yet what and who is? - but its successes speak for themselves. To break up the crew who saved the world before and struck decisive blows against our enemies would be foolish. What the world needs now is pragmatism and efficiency, not empty symbols. We need the best and most experienced in charge, not political appointees."

Adora wasn't an expert, but she didn't think that the Russians had suggested breaking up Stargate Command. Although they might have implied it.

The Chinese representative was next. "China recognises the successes of the American program - and its failures - but refutes the attempt to portray a direly needed international oversight and control of the Stargate as a mere symbolic policy. The Stargate is not merely the most crucial piece of alien technology but the one link of Earth to the rest of the Galaxy. As such, it cannot belong to any single nation but has to belong to the world as a whole and, therefore, needs to be under international control. It would indeed be a betrayal of the ideals of international cooperation if the United Nations were reduced to symbolic oversight while the Americans continue to run the program and make decisions for the entirety of Earth."

That had pretty much everyone nodding in agreement, Adora noted. "I think that's a good point," she whispered to Glimmer.

"It is," her friend agreed in a low voice. "But it doesn't really concern us. That's an internal matter for Earth. This meeting was supposed to be about the relationship between the United Nations and Etheria."

At this point, Adora was glad about any agreement. Yet, Glimmer was correct. "So, should we leave and let them hash out how to handle the Stargate?" Because, apparently, they still hadn't come to an agreement despite Adora thinking they had.

Glimmer snorted. “No. That would be rude.”

Catra, sitting on Adora’s other side, snorted. “What’s wrong with being rude?”

“It’s not done in diplomacy,” Glimmer replied with a slight frown. “It makes working together harder.”

“I don’t see much cooperation anyway.”

The British - or was that United Kingdom? - representative spoke next: “As much as we understand the need for international control, we first need to define the nature and objectives of the Stargate Program. Is it meant to be a military project to wage war? Or a civilian agency responsible for the security of the Stargate? Or a diplomatic initiative to contact other planets for peaceful contact?”

“We’re at war,” the Russian delegate replied. “A war against an enemy willing to destroy Earth and enslave humanity. Anything has to be subordinated to winning this war.”

“China concurs. The military matters have to take precedence.”

“France agrees, although we should not neglect planning for the time after the war.”

“The United States does not dispute that the war is of utmost importance. And it is because of that that my country opposes reckless changes to the Stargate Program.”

“The Stargate Program cannot remain an American operation,” the Chinese diplomat retorted. “That is unacceptable.”

“Da. Russia proposes to form an international unit tasked with the security of the gate and subordinated to the Security Council.”

“France supports this and suggests that the current Stargate Command would form the core of this unit so the experience of the current staff will not be lost.”

“The United Kingdom agrees with the proposal.”

“China as well.”

This looked like they had agreed on that beforehand. So why the posturing in the council?

The American delegate didn’t look happy. “The United States has important concerns about this proposal. The Stargate Program represents an enormous investment of my country, and simply handing it over to the United Nations without compensation is not acceptable. Think of the precedent this would set if any nation, at great cost, develops new technology only for the United Nations to take it.”

“Like you took the Stargate from the United Kingdom?”

“You took it from Egypt.”

“That was covered in a treaty.”

“A treaty forced on Egypt at cannon point.”

Adora sighed, not bothering to hide her mood as the delegates started bickering again. At least it seemed as if they were making progress.

“I bet if the Horde were attacking Earth, they would quickly come to an agreement,” Catra said. “Do you think we should ask Priest to attack a country no one would miss?”

Adora struggled not to giggle at her lover’s joke. Well, she hoped Catra was joking.

*****

The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, August 21st, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter usually was happy when she was in her lab. Except for when she was desperately trying to find a solution to an urgent and deadly problem, but even then, there was a certain satisfaction to be found in giving your all and saving the day - not that she'd ever admit to liking that particular feeling.

But after spending so much time in Entrapta's lab, her lab in the Mountain felt… inadequate would be a polite description. Not primitive - while not as advanced overall as the Etherian's facilities she had visited, Sam had several pieces of Ancients technology. And as she had found out, Earth Computer technology stacked up decently well against crystal matrices, though the Etherians had a large lead in neural networks. Nor was it the fact that her lab was a little cramped - there were limits in the Mountain, and she had the space she needed. It wasn't as if she needed to pace to think.

But Entrapta's lab… lacked limits in more than one way. Whatever she needed, she got. And kept it. Space, tools, help. Sam felt a little isolated. She had her team - good friends - and there were other scientists to collaborate with, but when it came down to it, Sam was alone. Her against the world, in a way.

And there was the fact that Entrapta had a relationship. A potentially problematic relationship - Sam hadn't missed that even Adora and Bow seemed a bit wary of Hordak - but also a happy relationship as far as Sam could tell. Not that she had examined the issue. Or that she was jealous.

Well, she was a little envious. To work with the partner you loved… As much as she told herself that it was against regulations and prone to cause trouble, she couldn't shake that feeling. Well, with the Naquadah items recovered, and the Etherians back at negotiating with the Security Council and individual countries, Sam could focus on her work. That should help to get over this.

A knock at the door made her turn. Oh. The Colonel stood there, leaning against the doorframe with his arms crossed. "Carter?"

“Yes, Sir?” She tilted her head slightly and straightened a bit. As the professional soldier she was.

“Dr Fraser’s waiting for you for an examination. In case we got a bit too close to the zombie cube in Honduras.”

She didn’t smile at the name. The Colonel liked these kinds of jokes, and they were often funny, but it wouldn’t do to encourage him. She nodded. “I’ll make an appointment later.”

“Ah… it was kind of urgent,” he said, smiling almost apologetically. “Well, she did give me the impression that she wanted to examine you right away.”

“‘You’?” Not ‘us’?

His smile slipped a little, then widened but became less honest. “I already got poked and prodded.”

She frowned at that. The Colonel didn’t like getting examined. “Did she contact you first?”

“I went to get a thorough checkup,” he said. “Felt that I needed one - it’s been a while since the last, and we kind of travelled the galaxy.” He grinned.

The Colonel had gone to Dr Fraser and asked for a checkup? “Sir… is there anything…?” She trailed off. You didn’t ask your superior officer about medical issues unless it threatened the mission. But you’d ask your friend. And the Colonel had been acting a little… different lately.

“Oh, everything’s fine!” He smiled. “Better than fine, actually. That’s why I got a checkup. Turns out I’m at peak health, and while we don’t think it’s because of the zombie cube, it’s better to make sure.”

Peak health? She blinked. Oh. “The magical healing you received by Adora.” After he had been poisoned by those alien predators.

He nodded. "It's like all the 'accumulated microdamage' - which is Fraser-speak for growing old and frail, I guess - was healed."

"You were rejuvenated?" That was… She drew a hissing breath. If magic could offer eternal youth… People would go crazy. And if it was only Adora who could offer this…

"What? Not exactly." He shrugged, and she couldn't help noticing that it seemed a bit more graceful. And briefly wonder if his body looked any different now. "It's more like the growing frail part was done with. 'Peak health for my age', the good doctor called it. I'm still not twenty any more."

But, a voice in Sam's head said, he would be about as healthy as a twenty-year-old. And with the experience of a man in his forties.

She pushed the voice away into the corner of her mind, where all the other inappropriate thoughts went. The kind of thoughts that would make the Colonel call her a mad scientist. Or something else she didn't want to think about. At all.

"Carter?"

She hid her slight embarrassment with a sigh. "I'll report to medical, Colonel."

"Good. Sorry about that, but better safe than sorry, right?"

She chuckled at that. And hoped Janet wouldn't want to gossip about certain topics. Sam was… distracted enough watching the Colonel walk away.

*****

Geneva Airport, Geneva, Switzerland, August 22nd, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Adora? Adora! We've got a problem! A huge problem! A really huge problem!"

“What?”

“Hey!” Catra scowled as Adora, on whose lap she had been napping, jumped up, almost sending Catra from the bed in their cabin to the floor.

“Sorry!” Adora turned to smile apologetically at her.

“Adora!”

Then she whipped her head around and continued towards the door. “What emergency, Bow?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Did the Tau’ri blow up another of their countries?”

Adora opened the door, and Catra saw Bow shake his head. “No! Worse! Priest watched television!”

Adora blinked. “What?”

Catra frowned. Why would that…? She gasped. “He saw some of the nutcases ranting about us?”

Bow nodded with a grimace. “He’s calling for a holy war against the heathens. You have to stop him!”

Adora was already running, Catra hot on her heels. They skidded as they took a corner - Catra’s claws didn’t find enough purchase on the floor - but reached the bridge without trouble.

“...and I doubt that you have the authority to call for a holy war without asking Adora first!” Glimmer was telling Priest on the screen.

“Yes!” Adora cut in. “What’s this about a holy war?”

“Your Divine Highness!” Priest bowed so deeply, he almost disappeared from view. “I have seen the most terrible sacrilege! Insults so vile, they call for the blood of the heathen! I dare not

repeat the words - I choke on the mere thought of it, my blood is boiling with righteous anger! Such blasphemy demands the harshest punishment possible!”

Now Catra really wanted to know what the clone had seen. That reaction seemed a little excessive even for Priest. Then again, the clone was the most fanatical of Adora’s followers.

“Ah…” Adora grimaced, then frowned. “But a holy war in my name cannot be started without my permission!”

“Yes!” Glimmer chimed in. “I’ve been saying that all along!”

Priest ignored her. Catra had expected that - the clone had a habit of ignoring what didn’t fit into his plans. But he couldn’t ignore Adora.

“So, what happened?” she asked.

“But your Divine Highness! You cannot possibly expect me to repeat such… such heinous blasphemy!”

Adora blinked, then nodded. “Then send me this… recording. I will judge the matter.”

“As you command, Your Divine Highness, but I have to warn you again - it’s the vilest filth imaginable! I cannot fathom how anyone would dare to do this!” He turned his head to the side. “Send the…” He took a deep, shuddering breath. “...the recording.”

A moment later, the console on the bridge beeped. Catra beat Adora to it and quickly displayed the message on the side screen.

“And what do you think about the aliens and their demands, Reverend?”

“Those heathens are an insult to God! Not only do those vile temptresses entice our youth to follow their disgusting example and live in sin and debauchery, but they also use magic! Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live! Whosoever lieth with a beast shall

surely be put to death! That is what the holy book commands us to do when faced with magic and bestiality! And yet, our heathen government, faithless men beholden to money instead of God, is not only tolerating their existence - in the sky above us, making a mockery of heaven - but they plan to spread their poison in our godfearing country! We cannot let this happen! We cannot sacrifice our immortal souls for the false promises of evil magic! If we falter, if we fail, soon our country will harbour the vilest of sinners, eclipsing even Sodom and Gomorrah!"

"The government claims that the United States need this alliance to successfully battle the Goa'uld Empire. What do you say to that? They claim that your movement is putting the entire world at risk."

"Lies! Filthy lies! God protects his own! And God punishes the sinner! If we bend to those alien demands, if we abandon God, he will strike us down - with fire from the sky! Salvation can only be granted by God, not by vile witches from space who consort with animals and monsters!"

Catra shook her head. Yeah, that would rile up Priest. Hell, the line about not lying with beasts was making her want to go and claw the guy. She wasn't a beast! But if she lost her temper, Adora would take this even worse. "That's one of the more extreme ones, I think," she said, unsheathing her claws.

"Yes," Glimmer agreed. "Most don't go as far as this fool."

"See, Your Divine Highness? We cannot let such crimes remain unpunished! The man denies your divinity! He calls you a false goddess! He wants to kill you!"

Adora grimaced. "Yes, Priest. But we cannot declare a holy war over this."

"What? But why not?"

Adora faltered for a moment. Catra was about to tell Priest that he was not to question Adora's will, but her lover shook her head and

spoke up before she could say anything. “Because he is clearly insane, and we do not punish those who don’t know better because they are mentally ill.”

Priest blinked. “Insane? You mean… defective?”

“Ah… in a way, yes.”

“But defective clones are purged - restored. Should we apprehend the… insane man and restore his facilities, Your Divine Highness?” Priest tilted his head. “I think we can duplicate the process.”

They wanted to mindwipe the man? Catra hissed through clenched teeth as she remembered what had been done to her. No one deserved that! And she’d kill Priest before she let him do this!

But Adora was already talking again. “No! Absolutely not! We will not follow in Horde Prime’s footsteps! We shall tolerate this man and his followers and hope that they will see the error of their ways in due time.”

“As you command, Your Divine Highness. Your mercy is as great as your power!”

As soon as the transmission ended, Adora sighed. “This could have ended very badly.”

“Yes,” Catra agreed.

“Should we tell the Security Council about it so they can do something about this?” Bow asked.

“Yes,” Catra said.

“No,” Glimmer objected. “Freedom of speech is very important on Earth - remember what Daniel told us? If we ask to stop such talk, that’ll cause more trouble for the negotiations.”

"If Priest starts an orbital bombardment over the next blasphemy, that'll cause even more trouble," Catra pointed out.

"I think we need to ask SG-1 about this. They should know how to handle it," Adora said.

Well, it shouldn't hurt, in Catra's opinion. Probably.

*****

The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, August 22nd, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and that's about it. I've told Priest that he can't declare a holy war on anyone who insults me, and he should be obeying, but we thought we should discuss the situation with you."

Jack O'Neill stared at the screen on which Adora smiled a little embarrassedly. Hearing that the United States might have suffered an orbital bombardment by the very fleet that was supposed to protect Earth if not for some quick words by the resident space magical girl wasn't how he liked his day to start. "Right. We've got a fleet crewed by fanatical clones orbiting Earth. How could that have slipped my mind?"

"Probably because of the lack of sleep and all the other important things we had to worry about," Daniel oh so helpfully replied.

"It was a rhetorical question, Daniel," Jack told him.

"Ah."

"Are you telling me that your fleet almost started a crusade against Earth over a television interview?"

Right. General Hammond was present as well. And he sounded as amused as Jack felt.

Adora looked confused for a moment. "Yes? That's what I just told you. Although I ordered them to tolerate such people, so Earth

should be safe."

"For now," Glimmer added. "And it wasn't just an interview - the man was calling for the 'faithful' to murder us." She didn't look amused either.

"So, you could say that you guys started it." Catra, on the other hand, did look amused. Then again, her sense of humour was a bit like Jack's own - very dark.

"Anyway," Adora spoke up again. "We wanted to know if you have any ideas on how to handle that. The whole free speech and murder threat thing Daniel mentioned."

Jack raised his eyebrows at his friend, who was quickly blushing under the scrutiny of most of the room. "I did mention how important free speech is, at least for the United States. Although incitement to violence isn't protected."

"So why's the nutcase calling for us to be killed not in jail? Or dead?" Catra asked.

"Good question," Jack said before he could help himself.

"Well, it touches on erring on the side of caution when it comes to constitutional rights," Daniel said. "And this also touches freedom of religion - he could argue that he was just quoting the Bible."

"So, murdering someone's alright if it's for religious reasons?" Catra scoffed. "We should tell Priest that."

"No, no!" Daniel blurted out. He probably hadn't caught that Catra was joking. At least Jack thought she was joking. "Quoting scripture is protected both by free speech and religious freedom. But you're still not allowed to incite violence."

Adora frowned. "He seemed to be pretty clearly calling for violence - here, let me send you the recording." Her frown deepened after a moment. "Uh. Your computers aren't compatible."

“Let me handle this,” Carter spoke up. She hit a few keys on her laptop. “Entrapta shared your protocols.”

A few moments later, Jack saw a broadcasting logo appear on her screen. And groaned. “You know, I was joking when I said we’d be doomed by US daytime television!”

The actual interview - if you could call the soundbite that - wasn’t funny even by Jack’s standards.

“Uh, well… This is obviously a very extreme and not all common view,” Daniel said, pushing his glasses up. “And the channel probably broadcast it to, well, raise a controversy. And get higher ratings.”

That would fit in Jack’s experience. “So, we’re going to get nuked for more ad revenue.”

“No one is getting nuked if I can help it,” Hammond snapped. He turned to address the Etherians. “We’ll have the government look into this. Please stay your hand.”

“Thank you.” Adora smiled. “I’ve told Priest that the person on the recording was obviously mentally disturbed and so couldn’t be held responsible for what they said. But I can’t keep using that excuse if too many say the same.”

“Oh, everyone knows we’re nuts,” Jack quipped. “It’s part of our charm.”

“Colonel O’Neill!” “Colonel!” “Jack!”

Oops. Jack knew not everyone shared his humour, but annoying three out of four - only Teal’c hadn’t scolded him - was a bit much.

Catra snickered, but Glimmer frowned. “In all seriousness, calling for our murders is not acceptable no matter how you excuse it. And other countries don’t have the same laws about free speech that you have.”

“Well, yeah,” Jack couldn’t help but shoot back, “they tend to like that they can lock up their people if they should disagree with the government. Or not agree fervently enough.”

Glimmer scowled at him. “That wasn’t what I meant.”

Daniel cleared his throat. “Well, authoritarian governments tend to limit free speech, so the United States historically tends to err on the side of caution. And that’s even without touching freedom of religion.”

“You know, I bet Priest would love that view,” Catra said. “And the idea that if it’s just a handful of people, it’s not a problem for the government.”

Was she threatening them - or warning, to be more generous - that Priest might send a hit-squad to Earth and claim it was some rogue clones?

“We will inform the government,” Hammond repeated himself, “and get back to you. Please ensure that there are no incidents in the meantime.”

“We’ll do our best,” Adora said. “Please solve this.”

Once the connection was cut, Hammond sighed. “What a mess. The President will have to hear of this.”

“There’s not much he can do about it,” Daniel said. “He can’t limit free speech. The Supreme Court was pretty clear on how limited the exception for inciting violence is.” Jack stared at him, and Daniel flushed. “I had to write an essay in high school.”

“Once we’re formally at war, the President will have more options,” Hammon said. “But this isn’t the 1940s any more - we can’t just reintroduce censorship.”

“We might have to,” Jack said. “If only to keep the nutcases from triggering a crusade against us. It’s like yelling fire, only not in a crowded theatre, but when facing a machine gun.”

“There’s a lot we should be doing but can’t,” Hammond said.

Well, Jack couldn’t disagree with that. But that didn’t help with solving this problem. He was no lawyer or scholar, but he was pretty sure that endangering an entire country wasn’t covered by free speech. Or shouldn’t be.

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Public Relations Part 1

The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, August 23rd, 1998 (Earth Time)

"You know, this feels a little dishonest," Bow said as he stepped onto Darla's ramp. "We're supposed to negotiate with the United Nations right now."

Adora felt a pang of guilt. They had claimed an urgent issue to bow out of the negotiations. Then again, they hadn't actually done much during the last session, except for answering a few questions and not taking anyone's side while the supposedly greatest powers of Earth bickered.

And, this was urgent - if Priest or one of his followers lost control upon stumbling onto another rant, the consequences could be catastrophic. Adora had seen records of what happened when a Horde fleet conducted orbital bombardment, and Priest hadn't really understood the concept of collateral damage last time they had discussed the issue.

"Bah! We were due a break!" Glimmer replied.

"This isn't actually a break," Catra said as they walked down the ramp. "It's work."

"But it's work with friends!" Entrapta objected. "I'm happy to see Sam again. I bet we have a lot of data to exchange! I can't wait to show her my prototype tiny keyboard!"

Adora wasn't an expert, but she wouldn't have thought that it took a prototype to build a miniature keyboard. Entrapta probably added a lot of functions to the thing.

Jack, Daniel and Teal'C were waiting for them at the foot of the ramp. Jack looked a little uncomfortable, Adora noticed.

"What's wrong?" Catra must have noticed it as well.

“I’m still not used to conducting such business out in the open. We’ve spent years keeping this secret,” he replied, and now we’ve got alien visitors landing right next to the mountain in their spaceship.

“We’re on a military landing pad,” Glimmer said with a frown.

“But it’s open to satellite surveillance. I bet your flight was tracked by half the country.”

“We’ve told the Security Council that we had urgent business with Stargate Command regarding a diplomatic incident,” Adora said.

“You did…?” Jack closed his eyes and sighed. “Of course you would.”

“Honesty is the best policy,” she told him.

“Yeah…” He grimaced. “Are you familiar with ‘white lies’?”

White lies?

“That’s when you tell a little lie because being honest would be rude,” Daniel explained. “Like you don’t tell someone that their favourite painting looks ugly, for example.”

“Ah.” Well, that wasn’t a real lie. You shouldn’t be rude to people.

Catra snickered. She probably thought this would excuse being rude. Well, they had more important problems than that. Like some people trying to rile up Third Fleet - well, they didn’t know about Third Fleet, but still! Since when was it acceptable to insult people like that?

“So, General Hammond talked to the President about the whole thing,” Jack told them as they entered the bunker - the Mountain it was called, Adora reminded herself. “It’s a tricky problem.”

Adora didn’t need to see Glimmer to know her friend was rolling her eyes. “If it were easy, it wouldn’t be a problem, would it? But

why exactly is it a problem to do something about people calling for our deaths? Isn't murder illegal in your country?"

Catra snickered.

"It's not quite the same," Daniel said. They reached an elevator and stepped inside. "Freedom of speech is one of the most important rights in the United States. Limiting it is… a very delicate prospect. Many people fear - not entirely unjustifiedly - that such a limit would just be the first step towards abolishing it entirely."

"No one likes censorship," Jack said.

"You censor your entire media. You censor *bad words*!" Glimmer objected. "So, it's not allowed to curse on television, but you're allowed to tell people to murder others? You've got some *fucked-up* priorities!"

"You're not the first one to point this out. But I would wager that your countries have some traditions and peculiarities that seem weird to others as well, right?" Daniel smiled.

"The princesses are all weird," Catra said. "You should've seen them at the Princess Prom."

"That's a matter of perspective," Bow cut in while Glimmer glared at Catra. "Every kingdom has its own traditions, yes. But few of them would be able to trigger a war. Those that did kind of… did that in the Age of War, and well, that settled most of them. Violently."

Glimmer frowned at him, but Adora nodded in agreement. Etheria wasn't perfect.

"That sounds like 'an armed society is a polite society', just for countries," Jack commented. "I don't think that's a good role model."

By the time Daniel had explained what the saying meant, they had reached the meeting room in Stargate Command.

"Welcome," General Hammond greeted them. "And thank you for coming to discuss this issue." He pointed at a tall, thin man next to him. "This is Mr Smith, representing the Department of Justice."

"Hello." The man smiled, but it looked like he was just being polite. Or he was nervous.

"Hello!" Adora smiled at him. "Thank you for coming!" They were here to work together, after all. She shook his hand - he didn't have a firm grip, but he wasn't sweating, either.

"So, what can you do about this?" Glimmer said as soon as they had taken their seats. "We've told Priest to treat those people as insane, but that might not be a permanent solution."

"You think he will disobey a direct order from his 'goddess'?" Hammond asked.

"Priest has a tendency to, ah…" Adora trailed off. How to say this?

"He thinks he knows what Adora wants and doesn't think he should ask her to make sure," Catra said.

"Yes, that." Adora nodded and pointed at her.

"Like every religious fanatic ever." Jack grinned.

"Although God doesn't answer questions, unlike Adora," Daniel said.

"Well, we should treat this as a legal problem, not a religious one," Mr Smith said. "Unfortunately, the Supreme Court has defined the limits of Freedom of Speech quite strictly in several rulings. Inciting violence, for example, needs to be imminent - and this isn't the case here."

“Can’t your court redefine that?” Adora asked the obvious question.

Judging by the man’s grimace, no, the court couldn’t do that.

“You see, the separation of power is the foundation of our country. The President can’t order a judge to rule a certain way,” Mr Smith confirmed Adora’s assumption.

“Ah, the famous checks and balances,” Catra commented.

“Why, yes.” Mr Smith smiled at her.

Adora closed her eyes for a moment when Catra smiled back, showing her fangs. “Be nice,” she whispered.

To her surprise, Catra didn’t mention, as she had done before, that it was the same as the Horde leaders’ policies of fostering the rivalry amongst Force Captains so they would keep each other in check. Instead, Catra shook her head. “But shouldn’t there be an emergency rule or something? If a decision threatens your world?”

“Not that there is currently a threat to your world - from Priest, at least,” Adora quickly cut in before someone could mistake Catra’s comment as a threat. “But it’s a potential threat. Kind of. A danger?” She pouted at the glance from her lover. And at the groan from Glimmer.

“Well, if our performance faced with global warming is any hint, then no,” Daniel said.

“Well, it’s not quite cut and dry,” Mr Smith said. “The President will talk to the broadcasting companies and voice his concerns about the risks to international relations that certain interviews might cause. This should cut down on the, ah, screen time of such extremists.”

“Remind them how the First World War started when you’re at it,” Jack interjected. With a grin, he added: “I think some journalists

have forgotten that not every royal is a figurehead. Some have space fleets with big honking space guns at their beck and call."

"Yes, that will be mentioned." Mr Smith's smile looked more than a little forced.

Glimmer smiled. "And what if they won't comply?" She leaned forward. "It's hard to work together if we have to wonder who amongst your people is waiting for a chance to kill us for their god."

"Our soldiers are thoroughly vetted," General Hammond protested.

"Yes. Those here," Catra said. "And once we're expanding operations from a few small teams to massed troops?"

"That might be a problem," the general admitted. "Although censoring broadcasting won't solve this."

"Battling worship of false gods is part of our mission," Teal'c commented.

"Yeah…" Jack grimaced. "Teal'c, I fear the US Army can't declare war on God. We've got laws against that. Freedom of religion and all that. Separation of church and state, and everything."

"They would crucify us in Congress and in the courts," Mr Smith whispered.

"Not on your god - on a false god," Teal'c replied. "You did tell me about your god, about his message of love. It is clear as day that your god would never condone murdering people simply for their choice of partners. Therefore, those people are worshipping a false god." He nodded.

Mr Smith looked as if he had eaten something that didn't agree with him. And Catra grinned. "Yeah. False gods are false gods, aren't they?" she asked, cocking her head.

"It's not quite the same," Daniel replied. "Goa'uld declare themselves as gods and demand worship when they manifestly, provably aren't gods - they merely use technology to fake their divine powers. That's what makes them false gods. The god those extremists worship is a different case since they aren't, well… the only claim that they exist is made by those who already worship them. No one is actually claiming to be god."

"Well, those who do are in the loony bin," Jack said.

"That's not entirely correct," Daniel turned to look at him. "Several people were and are worshipped as gods."

"And did they demonstrate any divine power?" Jack raised his eyebrows. "Loony bin."

General Hammond cleared his throat. "This is a political and not a theological problem."

"It's both, actually," Daniel retorted.

Entrapta frowned. "If the Goa'uld are false gods because they use technology to fake their divine powers, then what's a true god? And what are divine powers?"

"Well…" Jack shrugged.

"They aren't actually defined. It's a question of faith," Daniel said - a little too quickly, Adora thought. "It's like… we can't define a true god, but we can define false gods."

"Ah." Entrapta nodded. "So, unless a god makes a claim that can be proven or disproven, they can't be judged, right?"

"Ah… yes." Daniel nodded.

Well, that sounded confusing, but anything that didn't lead to someone claiming that Adora was a goddess was fine in her book. The last thing Adora wanted was to be worshipped.

"But that doesn't give us a solution to handle those nutcases," Catra said. "We're going to keep Priest on a short leash, and Adora will tell him and his followers very clearly that they aren't allowed to attack Earth without her permission, but what are you doing about your fanatics? Just pretending that they don't exist won't work."

"And how can we convince them to stop trying to murder us if we can't prove that their god is wrong?" Entrapta asked.

Mr Smith's smile was so thin, it was barely visible. "We're working on that. For now, I think restricting their reach will already significantly reduce the threat they pose."

Adora wasn't sure that she would agree with that assessment. But she didn't have a better idea.

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Samantha Carter didn't sigh with relief when the meeting with Smith finally ended - well, the official meeting; apparently, Glimmer had some questions, probably pointed ones, about the general US policy with regards to censorship. But Sam certainly felt like sighing.

Entrapta, on the other hand, sighed loudly when they started towards Sam's lab. "Wow, your politics are more confusing than I remembered." She cocked her head to the side. "Wait - they are confusing because I wasn't aware of your stance towards censorship and broadcasting, so maybe I should reword that."

Before Sam could weigh in, Entrapta shrugged. "Anyway! I've got the prototype of the tiny keyboard here! Once we incorporate your additions, we can finally communicate easily and in an ethically appropriate way with the captured Goa'uld!"

My additions? Sam wasn't sure what kind of additions she would make to a miniature keyboard. Well, maybe some added security features so it couldn't be dismantled and used to escape a cell, and she would have to check the software and encryption to

ensure that no one could compromise the data, probably some proprietary protocols so it could only communicate with a specific computer…

She was still pondering possibilities when they reached her office, but as she quickly found out, Entrapta had several of them already incorporated. Not all of them, though, and both of them spent half an hour hashing out interfaces that would be safer from hacking than the standard ones.

"I think that's it," Entrapta finally declared. "It would be a tiny bit safer if we used crystals, but you can't produce them yet, and this is meant to be built and maintained on Earth."

Sam wasn't aware that this was a requirement, but it made sense; in the current political climate, any solution that required alien resources would be more difficult to implement unless it was clearly superior to the alternative. And a single percentage improvement wasn't worth it. "Yes. I think we can construct that in an hour."

"So, give it to your… wait! You don't have bots. I forgot, sorry!" Entrapta blurted out. "That's something we should work on, actually - constructing anything goes much easier with bots."

"Autonomous robots are a security issue, I am afraid," Sam replied. She had asked before, after all.

"Yes?" Entrapta cocked her head to the side.

"There are concerns that they could either go out of control or be taken over by an enemy," Sam explained.

"Oh. Well, that can happen - it happened to me when I worked on analysing what turned out to be a First Ones computer virus; all my bots went berserk and tried to kill my staff and me. The others fixed it, though. And it gave me so much data!"

Sam forced herself to keep smiling. While she was aware that sometimes, you had to take risks for science - and be willing to do

so - her friend seemed to treat a potentially fatal incident as just another opportunity to gather data. But that was her way. “Well, we’ve got a lot of people here in the Mountain,” she explained. “They would all be at risk.”

“Right. You really need a secure lab in orbit or on the moon,” Entrapta replied.

“I’ll see if I can get the budget approved,” Sam told her with a grin before she could stop herself. She blamed the Colonel’s influence.

“Yes! It’s sooo useful!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “I’ve had barely any complaints since I got a lab in space. Well, I was barely home, where people would complain about explosions, but that’s kinda the idea.”

“I see.” Maybe Sam should apply for a lab on the moon and see what happened. With the technology they had recovered, reaching the moon would be child’s play once they could build their own ships. Which, of course, would take a while, and the war would take priority. But a lab on the moon…

Entrapta sighed and sat down on Sam’s desk, letting her feet dangle. “I still don’t get your politics. They’re so irrational.”

“That’s because most people are irrational,” Sam replied as she started to fill out a request form to get the keyboards and base stations built.

“They shouldn’t be. And there’s irrational and irrational. If Netossa doesn’t want to work with Sweet Bee because Sweet Bee once was Spinnerella’s girlfriend, then that’s, well, silly, but I can understand it. But I don’t get how you can dislike someone for something that didn’t happen. We’ve never been to Earth, we haven’t done anything to those people who want us dead, so why are they like this? We’re here to help them. If we wanted to hurt them, we could just bombard them from orbit. We wouldn’t play silly games.”

That was probably Hordak's influence, Sam thought. "They don't see things like that. They have their own view of how the world works, and they fit everything into that." No matter how much they had to bend and break facts.

"That's stupid."

"Yes," Sam agreed. "But that's how people - some people - are. We have to teach them that they're wrong."

"That's kind of hard if they want to kill you."

"Yes. Fortunately, the vast majority of them don't really want to kill anyone. They can be reached with the right approach." Sam hoped that she wasn't wrong.

"And what is the right approach?"

Sam winced. "I think that's a question for public relations."

"'Public relations'?" Entrapta looked a little confused.

This time, Sam sighed.

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Earth Orbit, August 23rd, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...so those public relations people are experts on how to make people like you, and Sam said we should look into hiring one. She said every government and every big business had one."

Catra, leaning against the wall in Darla's hold, frowned a little at Entrapta's explanation. "That sounds like… Like a bit questionable." People who knew how to make you like them? She knew someone like that.

Adora nodded in agreement. She would, of course - she had been raised by Shadow Weaver as well. "Yes. It doesn't seem to be very honest. How can people trust us if we lie to them?"

“Oh.” Entrapta looked confused.

But Glimmer shook her head. “It’s another form of diplomacy, of sorts - you know, when you try to present your proposal in the best possible way depending on who you talk to. You don’t lie because if you get caught in a lie, people stop trusting you.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded.

Catra narrowed her eyes. Knowing what to say to whom - that was how Catra had managed to recruit Entrapta to the Horde.

“Well, you also have to consider how far you can and want to go,” Glimmer went on. “At some point, there’s not much difference between outright lying and omitting things.”

“People will feel that they have been lied to even if everything you told them was technically correct,” Bow added.

Catra rolled her eyes. That was obvious. No one liked being manipulated and made to look like a fool.

“And how far do we want to go?” Adora asked.

“We want a lasting alliance, so we need to show the people of Earth that we aren’t their enemies,” Glimmer replied.

“Yes!” Entrapta agreed.

“We’ve been trying that,” Catra pointed out.

“In diplomatic negotiations,” Glimmer retorted. “This is different.”

Catra shrugged. People were people. Even princesses, when it came down to it, were people.

Glimmer frowned at her even though she hadn’t said anything. “I think we all realised that we don’t really understand the people here.”

That Catra could agree with. “Yes. They’re all nuts.”

“Not everyone,” Adora objected. “But a lot seem to be a little…”

“Irrational,” Entrapta finished for her.

“As I said, nuts,” Catra said.

Glimmer sighed. “They aren’t crazy - not all of them. But they’re different. We need to understand them better, and I think such a public relations expert might help.” With a glance at Adora, she added: “It’s like preparing for Princess Prom: If we know what makes them tick and what they hate, we can avoid blunders.”

Adora pouted. “We still made blunders. Like with Frosta. I don’t think anyone liked us afterwards.”

“That was because Catra manipulated us,” Glimmer replied.

Catra didn’t react. It was true, after all. She had played them - and she had enjoyed it. Especially the dancing. In hindsight, she should have realised a lot of things back then. But she’d been young and stupid. Very stupid.

“So, we hire someone to teach us about Earth? Like Daniel?” Adora asked.

“Daniel is an archaeologist and historian. Not a public relations expert,” Bow said. “But probably someone like him, yes.”

“We’ll need to find someone we can trust, though,” Catra pointed out. “Such a person could easily manipulate us.”

“Yes.” Glimmer frowned. “This will be tricky. We might have to hire two or even more to guard against that.”

“Don’t the United Nations have such people? You said everyone has them,” Adora asked. “We could ask them for help.”

“But they would be loyal to the United Nations, not to us,” Glimmer objected.

Catra nodded. Negotiations were tricky enough - they couldn't afford to introduce a spy. And she was sure that anyone recommended by the United Nations would be a spy for one country or another.

"Well, we know there are many such people on Earth," Bow said. "So, let's talk to some of them and see if they make a good impression?"

Catra snorted. If someone made a bad impression, they obviously weren't competent at public relations.

"Yes. Let's put up a wanted ad!" Entrapta said.

"A wanted ad?" Adora asked.

"That's how you hire people - you put up an ad in a newspaper and online. Sam explained that to me." Entrapta nodded. "Well, you could also use a headhunter - which isn't what it sounds like, I asked - and then they would look for one."

"That would be more discreet," Catra commented.

"But we would have to find a trustworthy headhunter first," Adora objected.

Which would put them back to square one. Catra nodded.

Glimmer didn't look convinced. "I was thinking we would contact various public relations firms. Putting up an ad would make us look…"

"...like we need the help?" Catra grinned at the princess's scowl.

"We do need the help," Adora said, nodding. "But I think asking people is better. And we can ask our friends to help us look for trustworthy people."

"The Americans want to manipulate us like everyone else," Catra pointed out.

"Daniel is honest."

Catra had to agree with that. Daniel could be trusted - to an extent. "But his superiors aren't." Not even O'Neill.

"I trust Sam," Entrapta added. "So, we can ask her too!"

Glimmer nodded. "We have to trust someone, anyway."

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The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, August 24th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"The Etherians are looking for a spin doctor?" Jack O'Neill looked at General Hammond, then at Daniel and Carter. Carter blushed, which was a surprise. He raised his eyebrows.

"I may have mentioned the concept of public relations to Entrapta," she said.

'May'? Carter usually wasn't as… diplomatic. She must be really embarrassed. But this wasn't some private moment where a joke would be appropriate. They were in a meeting with the general. "And they've asked us for a recommendation?"

"They have explicitly asked for Dr Jackon and Captain Carter's help," Hammond replied.

"I don't know why they would ask for my help. I don't have any experience with public relations," Daniel said. "I don't even know a public relations expert."

Jack was already aware of that. Otherwise, his friend probably wouldn't have blundered into the whole 'cuckoo archaeologist claims aliens built the pyramids' debacle.

"I am familiar with the concept, of course, but I don't know any public relations expert either," Carter added. "Entrapta must have got the wrong impression from my explanation."

Hammond looked grim. “This poses a problem, of course.”

Daniel looked confused, but Carter grimaced. Jack nodded. “Washington wants us to recommend specific ‘experts’.”

“Yes.” Hammond didn’t like the idea either. “I did point out that the Etherians specifically asked for Dr Jackson and Captain Carter because they trust them.” He sighed. “The President pointed out that whoever the Etherians picked would be approached by various groups anyway.”

“Like the NID,” Jack said. “Or just some interest group with a bag full of money. Or some foreign spy.”

“Exactly.” The general nodded. “However, I could persuade the President that we cannot afford to lose the Etherians’ trust in SG-1, so he agreed that we’ll be putting our cards on the table from the start.”

“Honesty is the best policy,” Daniel agreed.

Although… “Were you just quoting Adora?” Jack asked.

Daniel flushed a little. “It’s a sound policy.”

Maybe we should start worrying about the Etherians manipulating our own people, Jack thought. Though could you call it manipulation if they were simply being themselves? “So, how do we honestly recommend a trustworthy spin doctor that won’t sell out either the Etherians or us?” If such a person even existed - Jack didn’t really trust any PR guys.

“We investigate them beforehand,” Carter offered - she must have been thinking about this for a while. “As if we were screening applicants for Stargate Command recruitment.”

“Right. Because we’ve done this before.” Although Jack knew that despite their best efforts, they would have missed some NID moles in the past.

"And we'll tell the Etherians that," Daniel insisted. "They need to know that whoever we recommend will be loyal to the United States."

"Of course," Hammond agreed.

"Let's hope that they won't take offence at that," Jack said.

"They shouldn't." Daniel frowned a little. "They are, despite their age, experienced politicians, after all."

"Carter had to explain to them the concept of public relations," Jack retorted.

"That wasn't because the concept was unknown to them, but because they must have seen this as part of being a ruler," his friend protested. "And, well, because it was Entrapta. I keep telling people that we can't underestimate them. The Etherians have a sophisticated civilisation, even if their aesthetics might not look like that to us. It's the same with how people tend to see past cultures as ignorant and primitive even though most had complex societies. Like the Bronze Age, which had a complex network of trade and diplomacy relations that covered a significant part of the world and…"

Jack sighed. Here came the history lesson. Although his friend had a point about underestimating the Etherians. They were just so young. And so earnest. Well, most of them. Catra was a sneaky cynic, or tried to be, and Glimmer certainly acted like a politician often enough.

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Jack O'Neill pushed back with his seat and resisted the urge to spin around on it. With no emergency to deal with, he was supposed to catch up on paperwork. Which he had done - at least he had finished the essential reports. And what the government considered essential. Opinions on that differed, of course.

In any case, it was mid-afternoon-ish - time for a break. Usually, he'd drag Carter and Daniel out of their caves, but both were busy working with Stargate Command's support staff on vetting public relations firms. That left Teal'c. Who would, at this time, either by working out with the marines of SG-3, which meant sparring, or meditating in his room.

A quick check confirmed that Jack's friend wasn't in his room. Which meant he would be in the gym - and unlikely to take a break in the middle of a training session. Still, Jack felt like talking to a friend, and the mess hall was on the way, so if he grabbed a doughnut and coffee, he could then watch Teal'c flatten cocky marines in sparring matches. You could have worse breaks.

In the canteen, he stood in the short line - one airman ahead of him tried to surrender his spot, but Jack waved him off. As if he'd pull rank in the chow line! Besides, the TV was on and showing the news. Or what they thought was the news. Nothing new there… Wait! He frowned. He knew that face on the screen - that was the nutcase who had called for the death of the Etherians. He walked closer, listening to the announcer.

"...arrested for misuse of donations and child pornography. The reverend's lawyer refuted the accusations and claimed that his client was being framed."

An airman next to Jack snorted. "They always say that!"

Another cursed about paedophiles.

Jack would certainly not dismiss the idea that the good reverend was a conman and sexual predator. But he couldn't help feeling that the man's arrest so soon after he caught the Etherians' attention was more than a little suspicious.

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Earth Orbit, August 24th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and while the police refused to comment on the speculation that the reverend's recent controversial statements about the Etherians were the reason that his finances had come under scrutiny, several sources claim that despite the fact that the information about the reverend's suspicious financial activities was provided anonymously, the police acted as if they trusted the source, which raises suspicions that…"

"They arrested the nutcase?"

Adora nodded. "According to the news, yes."

"But not because of the death threats," Catra went on as she sat down in the lounge of Darla.

"Financial crimes and child pornography," Glimmer said with a deep scowl. "Figures."

Adora nodded, but Catra snorted. "Easy to plant such material on someone."

Adora blinked. "You think that someone, ah… framed him?"

Her lover shrugged. "It's possible. It's quite convenient that he was arrested - and for such despicable crimes - shortly after he made waves. If you can't get him for what he did, get him for something he didn't."

That was… Adora's first impulse was that this was bad. Very bad.

"We don't know that," Bow pointed out. "And according to what we found out, a lot of such 'televangelists' get very rich on donations."

And a lot of them didn't like people like Adora and Catra - they had said so in the past. Not many had been as hateful as the reverend in question, though. Still… "But child pornography?"

"It's not impossible either," Glimmer said, "according to the information we found about religious organisations."

“Of course,” Catra pointed out, “that also means it’s an easy and plausible charge.”

“But would they do this? Frame a man for crimes he didn’t commit just to please us?” Adora asked.

“In a heartbeat,” Catra replied.

Adora frowned at her. “We don’t know that.”

“We know they did such things - and worse than this - in their ‘Cold War’,” Bow said.

“But that was years ago,” Adora protested. When she saw Catra shaking her head with a sigh, she pouted. People could change - Catra was the best example! SG-1 were good people, too.

“But is this a bad thing?” Entrapta looked confused. “He told people to kill us - and we didn’t do anything to him. So, he was obviously a bad person who deserved to be arrested.”

“Yes, he was - but he might have been arrested for a thing he didn’t do,” Adora explained.

“But why would that matter, as long as he is arrested?” Entrapta asked.

“Two reasons,” Glimmer replied. “First, if he wasn’t arrested for telling people to murder us, then that means it’s still allowed to do that. Tell people to kill us, I mean, not killing us.”

“In the United States. In other countries, it is legal to kill us,” Catra interjected.

“We’re talking about the United States,” Glimmer told her with a frown. “Anyway, the second reason is that we have to wonder if we can trust people who break their own rules like that.”

“If a rule is stupid, it should be broken,” Entrapta said.

Adora narrowed her eyes - at Catra. She knew that quote.

Her lover frowned. “Hey, it’s true - you shouldn’t be following stupid rules.”

“Sometimes,” Adora admitted.

“This isn’t about following stupid rules - this is about trusting someone who ignores their rules when it’s inconvenient but won’t change them,” Glimmer explained.

“Ah. So, you think they will do the same when it comes to an agreement with us?” Entrapta asked.

“We don’t know if they did it in the first place,” Adora cut in.

“It would be wise to assume the worst,” Hordak commented. “Your friends in Stargate Command might be trustworthy, but they aren’t the rulers of their country.”

“And I’m sure that Jack’s been involved in such stuff,” Catra said. “Remember him and Burke?”

Oh. Adora frowned. “But that was years ago. He’s changed.”

Catra frowned as well - she understood Adora’s point. But she shook her head. “But there will be others. And either the President is behind this, or he tolerates it, or he can’t stop it. No matter what, it’s not a good thing.”

“Indeed,” Hordak agreed. “A leader must have total control over his underlings.”

“Yeah, how about we don’t go there?” Glimmer said. “But a leader is responsible for their people.”

“You can’t have responsibility without control,” Hordak retorted.

“This is getting a bit too philosophical. Can we focus on what this means for us?” Bow frowned.

“We don’t even know if our suspicion is true,” Adora told him. “We shouldn’t assume the worst without any evidence.”

“Neither should we blindly trust everyone,” Catra objected.

“I think we shouldn’t do anything, but we should be more cautious when negotiating,” Glimmer said.

“And what about the public relations experts we asked for help with?” Catra leaned back in her seat.

“We already decided that we would hire several people,” Glimmer told her. “So, we have to look for some people ourselves.”

“Great.” Catra, obviously, wasn’t fond of that idea. “Just what we wanted to avoid by asking SG-1 for help.”

Adora smiled and patted her lover’s back. “Not every plan works out.”

“But it would be nice if some worked out without having to work harder,” Catra retorted.

“You haven’t done much work in the negotiations at all, “Glimmer said with a frown.

“I’m not a princess,” Catra told her with a grin.

“Anyway,” Adora spoke up before her friend and lover could start a row - Catra was a bit lazy when she thought she could get away with it, but Adora didn’t think Catra being more active in negotiations would help a lot. Quite the contrary, in fact. “We should wait and see for now. And look for public relations experts. You can help me with that!”

She ignored how Catra sighed theatrically and slumped at the table. Catra couldn’t fool her with such antics.

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Earth Orbit, August 25th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter wouldn't call working with Entrapta a chore. Not at all - it was refreshing to work with someone as intelligent and driven as she was who didn't harbour some mixed feelings because Sam was a woman. The number of times she'd had to establish ground rules that should have been obvious with some of her male colleagues… the Colonel's jokes about her enforcing the pecking order had stopped being funny long ago.

No, working with Entrapta, a genuinely nice person as well, was a great experience, especially if they worked in space - despite Sam's experiences, part of her still marvelled at watching the Earth float beneath them through a window. At least it should be.

But part of her had also been dreading today's work on the ring transporter. Because while Entrapta was one of the nicest persons Sam knew - not counting when she had some mad scientist moment - she was also both very open and very curious. Which meant that she would ask rather uncomfortable questions that Sam didn't like answering.

"So…" Entrapta bit her lower lip. "Did you plant fake data in that guy's computer to arrest him?"

Questions like this one. "That would be illegal," Sam replied before she could help herself. Damn, That was an evasive answer if she ever knew one.

"Yes, I had that explained to me." Entrapta nodded. "It's a little weird that getting the right result but with a different method is not allowed, but apparently, the side-effects are bad."

"Yes," Sam agreed. "Breaking the law isn't a good thing."

"Unless it's a stupid law," Entrapta objected. "At least Catra said so, and Glimmer didn't really contradict her - well, not if she really meant it."

That was… a rather worrying fact. Not really a surprise, though - Catra certainly struck Sam as the type to only worry about getting caught with regards to rules, and Glimmer had a pragmatic side that bordered on ruthless.

"Anyway!" Entrapta nodded. "Whether or not it's legal doesn't answer the question I asked."

Damn. "Stargate Command didn't do anything like that. And I have no knowledge of any other organisation of the United States framing the reverend," Sam replied.

"But would you know about that?"

"No," Sam admitted. "Whoever would have done such a thing would have kept it a secret from everyone because it would be illegal."

"That's a lot of 'woulds'." Entrapta pouted a little. "You usually don't use so many."

Entrapta was much more focused on this than Sam had expected - usually, the woman was focused on science. "I don't want to present speculation as facts," she told her.

"Ah." Entrapta nodded, smiling. "That's a good stance."

"But," Sam went on, "some people think the timing of this is suspicious. Usually, such investigations take longer before an arrest is made." The police generally weren't eager to make waves like this without solid proof. Certainly not when it concerned the leader of a local church. The white male leader of a Christian Church, a voice in the back of her mind added. But that was another subject she wasn't going to touch unless forced to.

"On the news, they said they had received information from an anonymous source." Entrapta cocked her head to the side. "Wouldn't that be enough to act?"

Sam pressed her lips together. “The police tend to act a bit more cautious when receiving such information. It could be an attempt to frame a rival. Of course, it could also be information from someone close to the reverend who was pushed to act after the man called for your deaths.”

Entrapta frowned. “But if they knew about his breaking the law, why wouldn’t they have said something before?”

“Perhaps they didn’t think it was bad enough to call the police - especially if they were only aware of the financial crimes,” Sam explained. “The police would have discovered the other crimes once they took his computer and examined it.”

“Ah. So, it’s possible that he did those crimes.”

“Yes.”

“But it’s also possible that he didn’t, and someone faked the data.”

“Yes.”

“Is there any way we can find out which is the case?” Entrapta frowned. “Because this seems to be an important question that should be answered.”

Sam sighed. “Not without breaking a few more laws.” Such as hacking the computers and electronic communication of a certain Senator. Though not even that would probably help - Kinsey was too smart to leave incriminating evidence on his computer.

“Your laws seem to need a lot of revising,” Entrapta said.

“Yes. But altering the law is hard - and that’s by design.”

“Why?”

“Because people need to be able to trust that a law won’t be changed on a whim. They need to be able to trust the government, and they can’t do that if they have to fear that

whatever was legal yesterday could be illegal tomorrow just because the president didn't like it. Especially if they invested a lot and expected to be able to keep doing it."

"Oh." Entrapta nodded. "Like investing a lot into an experiment and then being told you can't do it."

"Yes." Sam nodded.

"But why would anyone invest a lot in telling others to kill people?"

Sam sighed again. She really didn't want to discuss religion with Entrapta.

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Public Relations Part 2

The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, August 27th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So… that's the government-approved list of public relations experts." Catra craned her neck to look at the list in front of Adora. "Took you long enough. I would have thought sending us a copy of your payroll would be faster."

As expected, Daniel frowned at that. "We didn't get you a list of government employees," he said with a slight pout.

"We wouldn't have taken two days for that," O'Neill added with a smirk.

"Catra's joking," Adora said. "Thank you."

"Mostly joking," Catra corrected her lover. "I'm sure none of them is hostile towards the government."

"Few businesses are," Daniel said.

"None of them is hostile to their employers," O'Neill said.

"Colonel," Sam hissed.

"Just being open and honest," he defended himself. Then he grinned at Catra. "Besides, I'm sure you already assumed that anyway."

Catra matched his grin. "Of course."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "It's generally thought to be both rude and crude to point that out."

"Well, I'm no diplomat," O'Neill said.

“As a number of unsuccessful first contacts can attest to,” Daniel muttered.

“Hey! None of them was my fault… well, perhaps one or two…” Now O’Neill was pouting. “Anyway, here you got your list of American PR guys willing to sell their souls to land this job.”

“We don’t need their souls,” Adora said. “We just need honest advice and expertise.”

“Well, that’s good - I think they sold their souls already. Or would have, if Earth had magic.”

“That’s not exactly how magic works,” Glimmer commented.

“Yes. Unless that’s how Earth magic works. I’ve never heard about soul magic until Earth. It sounds fascinating!” Entrapta beamed. “Can we measure souls and analyse them without harming them?”

“It’s not quite clear if souls exist,” Sam said.

“Those are myths. Souls… well, it’s more a question of faith and belief,” Daniel added. “Not something you can measure. Or even see.”

That sounded like their gods to Catra: Imaginary things.

“Well, Earth tales of magic do seem to emphasise spirits and similar creatures,” Glimmer said. “As do your religions. So, it might be possible that Earth magic is focused on spirits.”

“That’s not quite the same as what we think souls are,” Daniel argued.

“Perhaps spirits are what happens when the original body dies, and the intangible consciousness hangs around?” Entrapta speculated.

“That’s very fascinating, I’m sure,” O’Neill said, “but we’re here to talk about public relations.”

“You don’t like public relations, do you?” Catra asked.

Jack frowned at her. “They’re a necessary evil. Too closely related to politics.”

“Politics aren’t evil,” Daniel protested.

“My experience disagrees,” O’Neill retorted.

Catra snorted. “Earth politics, maybe.”

“Well, Alliance politics were sometimes frustrating as well,” Adora said.

“We all know that,” Glimmer said. “Let’s talk about public relations.” She picked up the list. “So, we’ve got half a dozen names here. Groups, mostly.”

“Yes. We’ve vetted them,” Sam said. “They’re honest as far as we can tell - reasonably honest.”

“For public relations people,” O’Neill grinned.

Catra shook her head. “Your jokes are getting older than you.”

“Hey! Low blow!” he protested.

“Can we focus on this list?” Adora was getting annoyed. And not the fun kind of annoyed.

“Sorry,” Catra said in a low voice.

“Alright.” Glimmer read the list. “They’re in alphabetical order. No preferences?”

“Ah… no,” Daniel said. “We don’t really have much experience with this sort of business.”

“We were too low on the totem pole to need such people,” O’Neill explained. “And too secret.”

"You sounded like you had personal experience," Catra pointed out.

"I have personal experiences with the constraints PR shackled us with," O'Neill said.

"I think that means he wasn't allowed to be as snarky and immature as he wanted," Daniel said.

"Hey!" But O'Neill was grinning.

"So… I guess we'll just meet with everyone and see who fits us best," Glimmer said.

"And you need to work out how to pay them," O'Neill said. "They won't work for free."

"That shouldn't be a problem," Bow said. "I've looked up the prices for space travel - passengers or cargo. Just transporting a satellite or two should give us enough cash to pay for them. Or we could offer to take a people to the Moon or Mars."

Catra suppressed a smirk when she saw how surprised the others were. Well, except for Daniel, who looked pointedly at O'Neill.

"You're going to offer space travel for cash?" O'Neill asked.

"It's an obvious service we can provide. There isn't much competition, and it won't require us to give away our technology," Glimmer replied.

"NASA's going to love this," he muttered.

"They will - if they can be the first to hire you," Sam said.

"How much would people pay to be the first person to visit Mars?" Daniel asked.

Catra grinned. It seemed the obvious way to make money for trade hadn't been as obvious to Stargate Command. Well, did they

expect them to peddle their technology? Or hire out Adora as a healer for money?

As if Catra's lover would have accepted that. No, offering trips to space was the easiest way to get money.

*****

Washington DC, United States, Earth, August 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"I'm not a politician. I shouldn't be here," Jack O'Neill grumbled as he shifted in the - admittedly very comfortable - seat in the White House's waiting room.

"We're here to advise the President and the cabinet, not to make policy," Daniel said, looking up from his book. Carter didn't look up from her laptop.

"I'm not a consultant either," Jack retorted.

"Jack! This is just a briefing - you've done those before."

"Under protest," Jack lied.

Daniel rolled his eyes and went back to reading.

Jack frowned. He was old; he had a right to be grumpy! Besides, he was sure that they would get the blame for whatever crazy thing the Etherians did next. "They haven't put up an ad for space cruises, have they?" he asked, looking at Carter.

"No, Sir," she replied.

"You haven't looked!" he accused her.

"I have a program checking for such things," Carter replied.

That was impressive. Jack hadn't known that they could do that.

“And Entrapta said she wanted to run the ad by us before they put it up,” Carter added with a slightly embarrassed smile.

Jack groaned. “I was joking about the ad!”

“Well, Jack - how else would they advertise their services?” Daniel asked.

“By giving an interview?” Jack raised his eyebrows. “They wouldn’t have to pay a dime that way.”

“That’s true,” Daniel admitted. “How are they paying for an ad anyway?”

“Credit,” Carter replied. “They don’t have to pay immediately.”

Jack couldn’t help noting that Carter knew a lot about the Etherians’ plans. “Been getting cosy with your mad science buddy, have we?” he asked, taking care to keep his tone light.

“I’ve been cooperating with our prospective allies as per our last orders, Sir,” she replied, tensing a little.

So, his tone hadn’t been light enough. Damn. “I’m not judging you,” he told her. “I’m just a bit curious - and envious. They aren’t as cosy with me.”

“That’s because the alien you’ve got the closest rapport with is prickly and too much like yourself,” Daniel replied.

The alien he had what? Jack blinked. “What? Catra’s a kid! We aren’t alike at all!”

“She’s a veteran with a dark past and hides her feelings behind dark humour and snark,” Daniel explained. “That’s like you with cat ears and a tail.”

Jack glared at his friend. That was going too far. “She doesn’t hide her feelings at all. She’s quite blatant about public displays of affection with Adora,” he retorted.

Daniel blinked, opened his mouth, then closed it again. What was his problem? And Carter was now hunched over so much, her face had disappeared behind her laptop.

Oh. Jack cursed himself, but before he could rectify the misunderstanding - and it was a misunderstanding, damn it! - the door was opened, and one of the White House interns peered inside. "Colonel O'Neill? Captain Carter? Dr Jackson? The President is now ready for you."

"Perfect timing," Jack muttered as he got up.

"Pardon?"

"Nothing." He waved the young woman off. "Let's not leave the President waiting."

"Thank you for coming. Please have a seat!" the President greeted them warmly as they entered the meeting room. The rest of the cabinet was more polite than friendly. And Kinsey, who, of course, had to be here for some damned reason, didn't bother smiling at all.

In return, Jack bared his teeth as their eyes met. If anyone asked, it counted as a smile.

"So!" The President clapped his hands together. "Things with the aliens have taken another turn."

"I'll say," the Secretary of Commerce. "My phone hasn't stopped ringing since news about their latest idea got out."

"Which was supposed to be a secret," the Secretary of Defense spat. "You've got a leak in your department!"

"It could have been any department," the Secretary of Commerce retorted.

"Well, at least it hasn't leaked to the press yet," The President said.

“Would save the Etherians some bucks for advertising,” Jack said before he could stop himself.

Everyone turned to look at him. “They’re planning to advertise?”

“Apparently,” Jack said. He wouldn’t throw Carter under the bus. “They seem to want to do things by the book.”

“They have been watching Earth TV since their arrival, so they would be aware of many of our customs,” Daniel said. “And they couldn’t have missed advertising, even though that’s not really known in their home.”

“Will they apply for a license to operate commercial aircraft?” the Secretary of Transportation asked. “If they do, would we have to certify their craft?”

“We haven’t exactly asked them to get their spaceship certified,” the Secretary of Defense remarked.

“But they didn’t operate it as a commercial transport,” the Secretary of Transportation replied. “That’s different now.”

“You want to set the FAA on the Etherians?” The Secretary of Commerce sounded shocked.

“I wonder how they’ll take the fact that Darla is a thousand years old,” Daniel muttered next to Jack.

“Folks,” the President spoke up, “let’s not quibble over regulations. We all know that if we won’t let them do this, another country will jump at the chance.”

“And NASA will be pissed,” the Secretary of Defense added. “They’re already starting a crash program to get a Mars habitat ready.”

“But what if something goes wrong? What if there’s an accident?” the Secretary of Transportation objected. “What if a spaceship crashes on a city?”

“We can weather such a crash better than a complete crash of the economy,” the Secretary of Commerce said. “And if we alienate the aliens, that is what will happen.”

Jack clenched his teeth and kicked Daniel before his friend could blurt out something impolite. That was one of the reasons he hated politics.

“Surely it can’t be that bad?” the Secretary of Transportation objected.

“Have you seen the latest report from my department?” The Secretary of Commerce scoffed. “The global economy is reeling. People are worried about the war. The only thing that kept the stock market from crash-diving into crushing depths is the hope that the aliens will usher in a new golden age thanks to their technology - and even with that factor, the panic is greater, especially in many developing countries. And the number of startups that can’t get money is increasing rapidly because everyone thinks their ideas and products are already obsolete..”

“And in the established industry, people scale back their staff. We didn’t have large numbers of workers getting laid off yet, but it’s just a question of time if this continues,” the Secretary of Labor added. “They know that not everyone will profit from the coming tech revolution.”

“And even the corporations hoping to profit from the aliens are worried,” Kinsey spoke up for the first time. “Several aerospace industries reached out to foreign firms for possible joint-ventures, but the reception in Europe has been… less than enthusiastic.” He looked grim, Jack noted, but Kinsey was an accomplished liar. “I’ve called a few contacts in the United Kingdom, and they told me that their firms aren’t convinced that the United States will manage to get an alliance with the aliens.”

“What? We’ve been working closely with them - we just stopped some zombie plague and captured alien infiltrators!” the Secretary

of Transportation protested. “They haven’t even talked with the United Kingdom!”

“The British have been active in the United Nations,” the Secretary of State replied. “And they’ve been preparing the field, so to speak - they’re rushing through pro-gay legislation, so when they officially talk, they can present themselves as the most progressive country. It’s the same with the French and the Germans.”

“Their industrial leaders are putting pressure on them to make a deal, same as ours,” the Secretary of Commerce added. “Only, they can ignore the religious conservatives.”

“So can we,” the Secretary of Transportation retorted. “They’re not our problem. We can replace ‘don’t ask, don’t tell’ easily enough.”

Daniel cleared his throat.

“Yes, Dr Jackson?” The President nodded at them.

“The Etherians are aware of how easily ‘don’t ask, don’t tell’ - or something worse - could be reinstated by a new president,” Daniel explained. “And they are aware that you’re limited to two terms, Mr President.”

The President nodded. “And they’re used to monarchs ruling for much longer times.”

“Magical princesses,” someone muttered.

“Yes, Mr President,” Daniel confirmed. Jack knew he struggled not to add: ‘I’ve already told you so’. “And, well… they expect full rights for gay people. Several western countries are passing laws to legalise gay marriage.”

“Laws they can change much more easily than we can change ours,” the Secretary of Transportation grumbled.

"But they also don't have their nutcases screaming to burn witches on live television," the Secretary of State added. "We do. That's not a good optic."

"He was arrested," someone else said.

Jack winced and raised his hand.

The President looked at him. "Colonel O'Neill?"

"They voiced concern about a possible frame job," he said - carefully not looking at Kinsey.

"Great. The absolute monarchs care about due process," someone else sighed.

"Many of the more extremist religious leaders have been a bit lax with regards to financial regulations," Kinsey commented. "I feel that several of them will want to avoid drawing attention that might lead to an investigation."

"Will that be enough to mollify the aliens?" the Secretary of Commerce asked.

Daniel pursed his lips. "They also mentioned that it's hard to trust people who break their own rules and laws when convenient but won't change them. It's like… they do respect our customs - mostly - and understand that our legal and legislative procedures and rules are different, but they aren't as understanding when we don't follow our own laws. It's a trust issue."

"But they trust you," the Secretary of Defense said. "They consulted your team to hire PR consultants, and you've fought together."

"Yes, but that's a personal relationship which doesn't extend to the United States as a country," Daniel explained.

"So, as a gesture of trust, we need to change the laws." The President looked at Kinsey.

Kinsey nodded. “My people are still working on the other party. This whole magic business has several key members worried about their constituents. No one wants to be primaried for ‘consorting with witches’.”

“Actual witches, as I understand,” the President said. He sighed.

“But we’ve got leverage - we have the Stargate. And we have alien technology. And the most experienced and powerful army in the world,” the Secretary of Labor said. “Surely we could find a compromise?”

“We’ll lose the Stargate,” the Secretary of State told him. “The other nations in the Security Council are bickering over the details, but everyone is in agreement that the Stargate belongs to the whole planet.”

“And we can’t stand against the entire world,” the Secretary of Defense added.

“We’0ve got a spare gate, don’t we?” The Secretary of Labor looked at SG-1. “Can’t we hand that one over and keep the first?”

“Stargates on the same planet tend to interfere with each other,” Carter explained. “It’s not entirely safe running two on the same planet.”

“To be fair, with all a Stargate entails, it is hard to argue that they shouldn’t belong to the entire world,” the Secretary of Education said.

“And ‘one gate for us, one for the rest of the world’ won’t really go over well either,” the Secretary of State said.

“What about the war we’re fighting?” the Secretary of Labor asked.

That was Jack’s cue. After a nod from the president, he said: “The Ehterians have a space fleet. They need ground troops - but given our performance so far against the Goa’uld, pretty much any

modern military will have the troops to beat the Goa'uld on the ground if they have support from space." And between all of their countries, the Europeans had enough ground troops for that.

"So, we might have the most experience and the best troops, but we're not irreplaceable," the Secretary of Defense said.

"What about our alien technology?"

Jack glanced at Carter. That was her field.

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Dulles International Airport, Washington DC, Earth, August 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Hello, Mr Finnigan." Adora smiled as friendly as she could at the man in a suit. "Please have a seat."

"Thank you, Your Highness. Your Highness. Your Highness. Miss Catra. Mister Bow." The man nodded at all of them as he took a seat in Darla's lounge. He wasn't gawking around any more, unlike when he had entered the ship.

Adora glanced at Catra, who seemed ready to comment on her form of address. "Don't," she whispered.

Her lover snorted as the man opened his suitcase and pulled out one of the small computers with a keyboard that they liked on Earth - a laptop, they were called. Catra found the name very amusing for some reason she hadn't shared yet.

"So, Mr Finnigan, you represent Mackenzie and Sons," Glimmer said when the man seemed finished setting up.

"Yes. We're a traditional consultant firm specialising in public relations." He nodded, then added with a smile: "You certainly don't need any introduction - I think everyone on Earth knows you by sight now."

“I don’t think everyone has seen pictures of us,” Entrapta retorted at once. “And we’ve got data that there are several communities which do not follow global media. So, not everyone would recognise us on sight. And we also need to consider that not every human being has the same ability to recognise individuals based on pictures. So, I would say we are probably known to the majority of the population of Earth, but not to everyone.” She nodded several times.

Finnigan blinked, and his smile slipped a little. “Ah, yes, of course. Thank you for the correction.”

“No problem!” Entrapta beamed at him. “I’m happy to help!”

Glimmer cleared her throat. “So, do you know why we are looking to hire a public relations expert?”

“You want to get your message out to the people on Earth and control your image,” Finnigan replied at once. “Mackenzie and Sons specialise in that sort of task. Whatever your message, we can get it out - and make people accept it.”

Adora frowned a little. “Whatever our message?”

“We’re professionals, Your Highness.”

“Just Adora,” she interrupted him. ‘Your Highness’ reminded her of how Priest addressed her.

“Certainly, Adora. Anyway, we’re professionals - we don’t care about your message or your goals, only how we can present them to your target demographic in the most effective way possible.”

He didn’t care about their message or their goals? Adora blinked.

“Sounds very mercenary,” Catra commented.

His polite smile turned a bit more genuine, or so Adora thought. “That is one way to look at it. We don’t judge our clients or try to

influence them - we don't have a horse in any race. All we want is to do our best to help our clients."

"And to earn money," Glimmer said.

"Of course."

"But what if we had goals that would run counter to your personal principles?" Bow asked.

"As I said, we're professionals. Whatever the client wants, they get. Our own private views play no part in this. We've worked for politicians from both parties in the USA - usually at the same time, albeit in different areas."

"I see." Glimmer's smile was also very polite.

*****

"...and I was thinking that you are a shoo-in for the younger market - the younger demographics. They can identify with you. They, too, are faced with a world of adults who do not take them seriously due to their age, and they often feel alienated from their parents because of their different life experiences. And, of course, you already cover part of the teenage pop culture - magical princesses? Catgirls? The ads practically write themselves! What you mostly need help with are the older generations." Miss Glendale beamed. "And we at PR Solutions Inc. know how to catch them. Leave it to us, and you'll reap the benefits of a targeted campaign in no time!"

Adora had the distinct impression that Miss Glendale, who was about forty, didn't really take them seriously either.

"I think for the older generation - especially those who remember the Second World War - we should focus on your war experiences. That will create common ground. Of course, you'll have to manage your appearances; what appeals to the younger demographic won't appeal to the older demographic. I would suggest you split your appearances. Some of you focus on the

younger targets - I would think you, Adora, and Catra, are best suited for that since they are the most tolerant demographic and you fit several popular archetypes in comics and animation - while Queen Glimmer should focus on the older demographic. We'll have to see what the polls say about your choice of partner to decide whether or not to emphasise your relationship in contrast to Adora and Catra's or not. But I think with careful brand managing, your approval rates should soar."

Adora wasn't sure if she wanted to be managed. But she was sure that she wasn't a brand.

*****

"I'll be frank - you've got some real issues when it comes to public relations. I took the liberty to have our data department run some polls in preparation for this interview, and, honestly, you're very polarising. The liberal urban population is poised favourably towards you, especially the younger generation, but the politically active part of that demographic is somewhat sceptical of your political views with regard to democracy. And the fringe groups there are concerned about being colonised. Still, that's your core support demographic - they share a number of your values and can be worked with." Mr Brown, of 'Brown, Wallander and Co.', nodded.

"However, on the other end of the spectrum, the Evangelicals are, at best, very sceptical. At worst, they loathe you. You represent everything they fear - you're literal aliens, you have same-sex and interracial couples, you don't follow their religion and you can do magic. And you're very open about everything." He took a deep breath. "And between those, you have the average American - they're sceptical, worried about the war and the changes that your arrival will cause to their lives, but also hesitantly optimistic. You need to convince those that you're not here to destroy their way of life but to help them if you want their support. Brown, Wallander and Co. can help you there, but whether or not they will be convinced depends on your actual plans for the planet."

The man - middle-aged and balding - sounded quite… Adora would say 'professional', but Finnigan had called himself that, and she didn't want to associate Brown with that.

"And, of course, this all depends on what is your ultimate goal," the man went on. "Do you need popular support to put pressure on the government? Or on certain factions in Congress?"

"We would like it if we didn't have to fear that whatever changes to your laws the current President does, the next one undoes - after we have shared our technology and magic," Glimmer summed it up. "And, as far as we know, for some reason, the people who loathe us have a comparable greater influence on your politics than their numbers and economic power would suggest."

"And that is because your democracy is weirder than most other democracies we saw," Catra added.

Brown nodded with a wry smile. "Yes, the system does favour certain demographics. Which in turn, means politics favour them. But changing - breaking up - that conservative alliance will be difficult. Not impossible - you already have big business on your side, so to speak, and the big donors are putting pressure on the usual suspects to change their policies - but a lot of the politicians involved need the Evangelicals to keep their positions."

Adora frowned. Such people shouldn't be in power.

"So, what can we do?" Bow asked.

"We - that is, Brown, Wallander and Co. - can help you with battling the Evangelical propaganda." Brown nodded. "But you won't really convince the hardcore Evangelicals since, in their eyes, you are a threat to their way of living."

Adora shook her head. "We aren't. All we want are equal rights for people like us."

Brown's smile turned sad. "They see that as a threat because their way of life includes forcing their views on everyone else. So, don't expect miracles. Some of them can be reached, but many, perhaps even most, won't change."

"Which means we need to hit the switch voters?" Catra asked - she and Adora had read up on American politics, though Adora didn't think that was the correct term.

"In a way. You mostly need to convince most of the rest of the conservative base that legalising gay marriage and magic isn't going to turn them into gay witches."

"They actually believe that?" Adora blurted out.

"Yes." Brown nodded. "Part of the reason for that is, of course, that no one really knows what magic can do. The rumours of a zombie plague didn't help there."

Adora winced.

"Well, we don't exactly know what Earth magic will do," Entrapta spoke up. "But based on your myths and history, I don't think the sexual preferences of people will be changed."

"I see." Brown slightly inclined his head. "In any case, Brown, Wallander and Co. can help you improve your image in the United States. No more and no less."

"Thank you, Mr Brown. We'll contact you once we have made our decision," Gimmer said.

*****

"...and if you want to improve your image, you need to optimise your presentation. Get people to focus on your strengths and ignore your flaws. Give the public what they want. You're young, attractive and fighting evil body-snatching aliens. That's enough to forgive a lot of sins - people love war heroes. Keep your private life private, and you'll have them singing your praises soon

enough. Of course, if you really want to gain the Evangelicals' support, then converting to their faith would be a big help - they love repenting sinners." Alois Baker, of Smith and Baker, flashed pearly white teeth. "As long as you go through the motions, you're set and can do what you want in private. Most of them do the same, after all."

"Thank you," Adora lied. "We'll stay in touch."

*****

"Frankly, trying to correct your image by catering to the kind of people who rant about hell and damnation is a fool's quest." Julie Callaghan shook her head. "You won't ever win over most of them - unless you're white, male, straight and Christian, they will never accept you as equals. You have to change them if you want them to stop hating you, and that will take a lot of time, and you won't be able to change all of them."

"That's kind of pessimistic," Bow said.

"It's realistic. You can't win them all, so you need to decide who you want to support you. I've advised several politicians and I've always told them that if they have to lie to gain the support of a group, if they have to hide their real self, play a role, put up a facade, then that will, sooner or later, blow up in their faces. Someone will tell on you and the truth will get out. And that will cost you a lot more support than any lies could gain you."

Adora nodded in full agreement. As did her friends. Well, Catra smirked, but that counted.

"But ignoring them won't really stop people calling for our deaths," Glimmer pointed out.

"Oh, you shouldn't ignore them - but you shouldn't bend over to cater to them. Stress what you have in common. Whether gay or straight, most people want a loving, happy relationship. They want their children to be happy and safe. You want them to realise that they aren't losing anything that matters just because

gay people can marry." Julie smiled before turning serious. "Of course, magic complicates that."

Adora sighed.

*****

"So, the first question you need to answer is: What do you want? What is your ultimate goal? Then we can find out who you need to target and focus on them. Don't waste your money on people who don't matter, I always say - targeted ads are where it's at. And once you have your target group defined, you analyse it and then go for the opinion leaders. The world works top-down - but, being monarchs, you'd know that, wouldn't you?" Mr Cassidy, of Cassidy Analytics, smiled. It was a nice smile, but a little… Adora couldn't really put it down, but it felt a little condescending.

"According to what we know, the United States are a democracy, and public opinion greatly influences policies," Glimmer told him.

"Yes, yes, polls make policies, I always say. But people don't make individual decisions - people are, by and large, followers. The democratic ideal of the informed voter, carefully weighing the pros and cons before making a decision, is an illusion. People don't think. They pick a candidate by gut feeling. Or because someone they trust told them to. And those people - the opinion leaders and shapers - are your targets." Cassidy nodded at his own words. "Let's take the Catholic Church. You don't change the opinions of the Catholic Church by appealing to the masses - you influence the Pope because the Catholics listen to him. Well, they listen, and then they break their own rules all the time, but the Catholic Church considers all of humanity as sinners for a reason, right?" Another smile appeared.

Adora frowned. That sounded… well…

"And who leads those opinion leaders?" Catra asked.

"Well, those who know how they tick and how they can be motivated." And again, he smiled. "You, if you hire me."

"But how do you influence people who believe that their god wants us to die?" Bow asked.

"Oh, they don't - the leaders never believe their own words. It's all an act." Cassidy chuckled. "They're too smart to fall for the lies they tell their rubes."

"You think every leader is like that?" Adora asked.

"I *know* it."

"Thank you. We'll contact you once we have made our decision," Glimmer said.

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Washington DC, United States, Earth, August 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and so it is my informed opinion that the United States couldn't match a program by other industrialised nations supported by the Etherians with a domestic effort of our own." Samantha Carter finished her explanation.

Or so she thought - the Secretary of Commerce frowned at her. "But we have more samples of alien technology than any other nation. And we have the most experience - I distinctly remember the budget for the Stargate program and the research into adapting advanced technology for domestic production. Are you telling me that all the claims made by Stargate Command were false?"

"No, Sir," Sam replied, managing not to frown. "I stand by our claims - but, as our reports clearly state, it will take considerable time until we can reasonably expect results - even accounting for the lack of secrecy now," she added before the man could bring that up. "We simply don't have the resources the Etherians can provide. We have a dozen scientists who have been researching alien technology - for the Etherians, this technology is what they work with. They can provide engineers and technicians to their

partners who have been working with this technology all their lives - and know it inside out."

Most of them were clones, as far as Sam knew, but there were hundreds if not thousands of former Horde soldiers who had experience building and maintaining Horde technology as well. She went on: "While we will be trying to teach our engineers and technicians the basics of the technology, the Etherians will be teaching their partners how to build and run factories for finished products."

"Ah."

"Our assets would, of course, use any opportunity to gain information and knowledge," Kinsey added, "but I don't have to explain to you that that would never replace such a deal."

"And it might be seen as an unfriendly act," the President added.

"It would be an unfriendly act," Daniel corrected him. Many glared at Sam's friend for his remark, but he raised his chin and weathered the hostility.

"So, you see - we need that alliance if we want to maintain our technological and miliary lead," the Secretary of Defense said.

"Easier said than done. The Etherians don't understand how our system works." The Secretary of State snorted. "Or, rather - they do understand, but they don't care."

"They're concerned about the extremist elements in our country," the Secretary of Education said. "And with good reason, I dare say."

"Tell that to the conservatives," the Secretary of State grumbled.

"We did speak with them," Kinsey said. "They understand the problem, but… they have some difficulties reining in the radical fringe they cultivated for so long."

“Die Geister die ich rief, die werd ich nicht mehr los.” The Secretary of Education chuckled.

“That’s from Goethe’s ‘The Sorcerer’s Apprentice’,” Daniel whispered.

“I don’t remember Mickey Mouse speaking German,” the Colonel replied in a whisper.

Daniel looked shocked for a moment - until he realised the Colonel was teasing.

“Well, their problems are now our problems,” the Secretary of State said. “We can’t get a good deal if people keep screaming to burn witches on live television.”

“We can’t limit Free Speech,” the Attorney General said.

The Secretary of Defense muttered something that Sam couldn’t hear. She was certain that it wasn’t a compliment.

“We could reclassify calling for a lynch murder as inciting violence,” the Secretary of Education said.

“We can’t keep people from quoting the Bible!” the Attorney General replied. “It would violate both Free Speech and Freedom of Religion!”

“We certainly could!” the Secretary of Education snapped. “If it’s done to incite violence, it shouldn’t be protected.”

“The press would crucify us,” the Secretary of Transportation said.

“The press will crucify us if we don’t get a deal,” the Secretary of Commerce retorted.

The President looked at the Attorney General. “Can you talk to the Supreme Court? Ask them if national interests would be

considered in a ruling whether or not the definition of inciting violence could be expanded?"

"I don't think they'll be receptive to that," the man replied. "They generally don't value economic interests higher than our freedoms. And they don't react well to any political pressure."

The President scowled for the first time. "Remind them that we're not just talking about the economy - we've got a fleet crewed by religious fanatics in orbit, and our religious fanatics are talking in public about burning their goddess and her consort. This is a clear and present danger for our country."

"Also, not too many of our allies agree that calling for murder should be protected by Free Speech," the Secretary of State added. "It's not as if we're talking about violating the UN charter of human rights here."

The President nodded. "Yes. I'm not asking to suspend our freedoms - I am asking for a bit of common sense."

The Attorney General sighed. "I'll see what I can do. Maybe we can use the lynching angle."

And the Colonel muttered: "Common sense? From lawyers?"

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Dulles International Airport, Washington DC, Earth, August 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So…" Catra stretched her arms over her head. "Who do we pick?"

"Not Smith and Baker!" Adora blurted out. "They're too…"

"..dishonest, cynical and smug?" Catra asked.

"Yes!" Adora nodded emphatically. "Too manipulative."

Catra pressed her lips together. That summed it up.

“Well, we want to manipulate public opinion, don’t we?” Entrapta asked.

“We want to improve public opinion - but not by manipulating people like Cassidy wanted to,” Adora retorted. “I don’t want to hire him either.”

Not like Shadow Weaver would have done it. “Neither of them cared about our goals and principles - only the end result.”

“And the end doesn’t justify the means,” Bow agreed.

Catra glanced at Glimmer, but she didn’t contradict Bow. Instead, she said: “And such manipulations tend to blow up in your face.”

Catra clenched her teeth. Like her own. She had been so stupid! She had been… A hand on her thigh distracted her. She looked to her side. Adora smiled at her, shaking her head. Alright.

“So, we’re all in agreement: Smith and Baker as well as Cassidy Analytics are out,” Glimmer said. “What about Mackenzie and Sons?”

“I don’t like them,” Bow said. “They didn’t seem to care at all about what we are doing.”

“They only care about money,” Catra said. Such people had their uses - but only if you didn’t have any other options. And you couldn’t trust people who were in it for the money. “They might sell us out if the offer is good enough. Or use what they learn after they stop working for us.”

“I don’t think they would still be in business if they did that,” Glimmer objected. “No client would trust them.”

“If they keep their knowledge for their own use, who would be able to tell?” Catra retorted. “I vote for not hiring them.”

“Yes,” Adora agreed.

“Me too,” Glimmer added. “That leaves…PR Solutions, Brown, Wallander and Co. and Julie Callaghan.”

“The woman from PR Solutions was pushy,” Entrapta said.

“And she talked as if we were children,” Adora added.

Catra thought the same. “She acted as if she would take over. But we’re looking for a consultant, not a commander.”

Glimmer scowled. “Yes. So, all in agreement that they’re unsuitable?”

Everyone nodded.

“What about Brown, Wallander and Co.?” Catra asked.

“I like their method!” Entrapta piped up. “He came with data!”

“And he didn’t make big promises,” Bow added.

“Yes. And he didn’t treat us like idiots,” Adora said.

“So, we’ll hire them. What about Julie Callaghan?” Glimmer asked.

“She seemed a lot like him,” Catra said.

“But she didn’t have any data,” Entrapta pointed out.

“I think she simply didn’t gather fresh data like Brown did,” Bow told her. “But her conclusions were close to his.”

“So… should we hire her as well? We need more than one consultant so we can check their plans, but if she thinks like Brown…” Glimmer shrugged.

“Well, if they have the same correct answer to the same question, then that’s a good thing,” Entrapta said.

“Yes,” Catra said. “But we need a few consultants who aren’t Americans. Or referred by the government.”

“Yes. But I think we should hire these two,” Adora said. “They made a good impression.”

“And their rates are reasonable. I think,” Bow said. “Compared to the others, at least.”

“Alright. Let’s hire them. And then see what we can do about those nutcases,” Glimmer said.

“And then see who else we can hire,” Catra corrected her. “And see how many trips to space we can sell.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “We need to get money to pay them, after all. Let’s hope we get enough offers.”

Catra snorted. Sometimes, Adora was an idiot. But she was her idiot.

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The Interview Part 1

The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, September 7th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"The visitors have arrived, Sir."

Jack O'Neill nodded at Siler. "Thank you, Siler." He sighed and got up. Usually, he'd appreciate any break from paperwork, but today… "Let's go give the commies the tour."

"Russia isn't communist any more, Jack." Daniel had to comment, of course, as they filed out of his office.

"They've still got the same people in uniform. Every one of their generals was in the Red Army," Jack retorted. "And the Chinese are communist."

"Well, that's a matter of debate," Daniel replied. "Some might claim that they are more capitalist than many western countries since their economic reforms took off."

"They're still ruled by the Communist Party," Jack shot back. Who had brutally crushed protesting students not even 10 years ago. Literally crushed in some cases, or so he had heard.

They collected Carter on the way. Teal'c joined them before they reached the elevator.

"And the British are ruled by socialists," Jack said as they stepped inside the cabin.

"Sir?"

"Just telling Daniel why calling our visitors 'commies' is perfectly factual, Carter," he explained.

"It's actually not," Daniel insisted. "And calling the delegation from the United Nations Security Council 'commies' would be a major

diplomatic blunder!”

“I’m not going to tell them that to their faces,” Jack assured his friend. “But I am permitted to be grumpy about a bunch of strangers coming and taking over.”

“Our government agreed with the decision,” Daniel said.

“Under protest.”

“Actually, they didn’t file any protest,” Carter said.

“Because that would’ve been bad for our image.” Jack snorted. It had probably been inevitable - not even the United States could defy the entire world. Especially with the Etherians willing to uplift, as Daniel called it, other countries. But that didn’t mean that he had to like it.

“Well, that is a consideration,” Daniel said. “But the Stargate is supposed to be for the entire world, so… we shouldn’t expect to be able to monopolise it.”

“Monopolising is a proud capitalist tradition,” Jack quipped as they entered Hammond’s office.

“Don’t make any jokes about communists, Colonel O’Neill,” the general told him. “The President himself told me to extend every courtesy to our guests.”

“My lips are sealed,” Jack replied and mimed zipping them.

Hammond snorted. “I don’t like this either, but politics are politics. We can but try to make the best out of this.”

“At least it’s going to be a military operation,” Jack said. “Some people wanted to put us under civilian oversight.” You couldn’t wage war like that.

Daniel was about to comment, as Jack had known he would, but Siler’s voice over the intercom informed them that the delegation

had reached their floor.

And there they came. Russian, Chinese, British and French officers. Undoubtedly taking in everything - this was, after all, one of the most important military installations in the United States even if you didn't count the Stargate.

"General Sidorov, General Li, General Haig and General Dubois, welcome to Stargate Command," Hammond greeted them. "This is SG-1, our best team."

"Thank you, General. And I think everyone here knows SG-1." Sidorov smiled. "We've met at the United Nations."

Jack returned the smile with about as much sincerity. Yes, he remembered those briefings. Or interrogations.

"And I think you've met Dr Georgovich already."

The Russian scientist beamed at them. "Yes! Hello! Fancy meeting you here, da? Who would have thought we meet again so soon!"

Just about everyone with half a brain, Jack thought. Too bad that telling Georgovich to drop the act would be undiplomatic. He glanced at Carter - she was smiling. She didn't actually like the Russian, did she?

"So, gentlemen, let me give you a tour so you can get an impression of how we run things here," Hammond said.

"Yes," General Haig replied. "We need to know that in order to determine how to transfer the entire operation to a more suitable location." He looked around. "While this is very secure, I can't see us operating an entire invasion through this installation."

"Or peaceful exploration and diplomacy," Georgovich added. "Bunker makes not good first impression, no?"

The General Sidorov didn't look angry that the scientist spoke up without having been asked a question. That told Jack a lot about

the dear doctor's standing in Russia.

"So the decision has been made to move the Stargate?" Hammond asked. He was taking that much better than Jack would have in his place.

"Yes. Although the new location hasn't been finalised yet," General Dubois answered. "The need of the new location to be accessible for bulk transport as well as being secure and easy to defend pose a slight challenge."

"And prestige warring with security. Great honour to host gate, but great embarrassment if gate invaded and need to be blown up," Georgovich said.

"It's a tricky decision indeed," General Haig agreed. "Completely out of our hands, though."

And that was another reason Jack wasn't happy with this. He didn't want to move to some foreign country where he couldn't go out and have a decent American dinner in town. It was petty, but after travelling the Galaxy - and getting shot at - he really liked heading home instead of to some barracks.

But there was nothing he could do about this.

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Dulles International Airport, Washington DC, Earth, September 7th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and I believe that it is past time to start giving interviews," Julie finished her, well, briefing. Even though she was a civilian. "Some members of the press are already portraying you as 'aloof' and 'distant', and the longer this goes on, the worse it will get. If you wish to improve your public image, you need to start talking to the press."

Adora frowned. They had been busy with negotiations and diplomatic meetings nonstop - even the so-called European Union

hadn’t actually spoken for their members. Apparently, the military alliance part wasn’t included in the Union. But since they regulated trade, they had a say about any agreement being made. Or something - even Glimmer was still a little confused about how this was supposed to work.

“Democracy in action.” Catra snorted. “Why is it that the people’s opinion only counts when it’s making trouble for us?”

“That would be because the media and the public in the United States have certain expectations that politics need to take into account,” Julie said. “And in true American fashion, they extend that to everyone else.”

“Charming,” Glimmer commented. “And once we start giving interviews, we can’t really stop until everyone got theirs, right?”

Julie shook her head. “You can stick to the most important ones. A snubbed journalist is one of the worst enemies you can make in the USA - if they have the backing of their employer. Some of them are so petty, they will portray everything you do in the worst light possible in retaliation. But if they don’t have the reach to cover the country, they can’t really hurt you no matter how hard they will try.”

“You mean they aren’t doing that already?” Catra asked. “Some of them could’ve fooled me.”

Adora nodded. “Do they really expect us to talk to them before we actually finish our negotiations with the United Nations?”

“In a word, yes,” Julie replied. “Some of them - most actually - will understand that you’re not American and won’t act like our own government. But a few have such huge egos, they think they have more influence on the public than the government and should be treated accordingly. And in some states, they would be correct. Now, some of them won’t really change their attitude and will use the interview merely as another source for their criticism. They are too invested in their fanbase. But others can be won over if

you handle this right." Julie slowly nodded. "But you will have to prepare thoroughly for this - a blunder could seriously damage your reputation."

Adora perked up. She was good at such preparations! "Oh, we can do that! We'll prepare as if this were a diplomatic mission of utmost importance!"

Glimmer sighed. "Oh, great - it's Princess Prom again."

Adora frowned at her friend. Granted, her preparations hadn't been as helpful as she had hoped, but that didn't mean they had been bad. If she hadn't prepared as extensively as she had, things might have gone worse. And her worst mistake had been that she hadn't accounted for Catra's presence, anyway - and that wasn't a problem any more!

Julie wrinkled her forehead a little. "Princess Prom?"

"The most important ball on Etheria," Bow explained. "All the princesses and their consorts gather at the Princess Prom every ten years. It goes back centuries, to the Age of War, and is used not only to socialise but also to negotiate agreements, alliances and settle disputes."

"Oh, yes," Adora added. "And the list of rules for it is longer than I am tall - as She-Ra."

"But you don't need to know all of them, just the most important ones," Catra said.

"You would think that - you blew up the last one!" Glimmer protested.

"You blew it up?" Julie looked… well, the most surprised Adora had ever seen her in the week since they had started working together.

"Not really," Catra said, making a dismissive gesture with her hand. "It was mostly a distraction. I didn't use decent charges."

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded. “Those were microcharges. Scorpia told me about them after I joined the Horde.”

“They caused a panic,” Glimmer said.

“And they caused Frosta to ally with us,” Bow added. “Even after Adora alienated her.”

“I was surprised at her age,” Adora defended herself.

“And she would have joined the Princess Alliance sooner or later anyway,” Catra said. “But others were scared off, and we got our objectives, so I’d say, overall, it was a qualified success.” She turned and flashed her fangs at Adora in that way of hers that made Adora feel butterflies in her stomach. “And I got to dance with you!”

“The dance that will live in infamy,” Bow said. “Or would, if there were any records.”

“Actually, there are,” Entrapta said. “I recorded everything for my research into social occasions and interactions.”

Adora felt herself blush a little. Entrapta had recorded that dance?

“Oh, great! I need a copy!” Catra beamed. “Did you record how I fooled Adora as well?”

“I think so?”

“You recorded the Princess Prom?” Glimmer blurted out. “But that’s against the rules!”

“It is?” Entrapta looked confused. “They said you weren’t allowed to use magic to record the events at the ball, but I used a completely different way of recording things!”

“I think you and I both better clear our schedule to prepare for your first interview, “ Julie commented.

Adora frowned. The Princess Prom had been an exception, and that had been years ago. Everyone had changed since then. And for the better.

But Julie didn't look as if she'd believe that.

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The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, September 7th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and this is the central vault where we store the recovered alien technology. While I'm not going to detail the exact security measures, you can see that it is quite secure," Samantha Carter said as she approached the vault and nodded at the two guards there.

"Yes, yes. Very solid door," Dr Georgovich said, nodding. "The walls - reinforced as well, right?"

"Of course," Sam replied. "It wouldn't make sense to have a reinforced door anchored to walls that you can easily breach."

"You would think, but sometimes, mistake happens. I saw vault that had door one metre thick, stainless steel, but the walls? Natural stone. You see, specifications only said thick door, not walls, and workers did follow specifications to the letter. Was very embarrassing for officer in charge when hinges broke out of wall and door almost fell on important visitor." The Russian eyed the door - no, the guards. "Ah, no flinching, they trust door. Good."

Sam narrowed her eyes at the man. "I can't believe someone would make such an obvious mistake." He had to be joking.

"Ah, you never visited Soviet Union, da? If door was your task but not wall, you only did door. Wall was other problem. You did your problem and done."

"Yeah, I can believe that," the Colonel commented.

“Ah, you’ve visited Soviet Russia, da? No comment or no confirm or deny?” Dr Georgovich beamed at the Colonel.

“Something like that, yeah.” The Colonel shrugged. “Anyway, that’s the vault.”

“So, can we enter? Just for a look - evaluate.”

“We do need to take stock, after all,” General Haig added.

“As long as you keep your fingers to yourself,” the Colonel said.

Sam would have frowned at him - suggesting that their guests might attempt to steal from the vault wasn’t very diplomatic - but they were under scrutiny right now.

So she had the guards open the vault and then stepped into the door - she wouldn’t let anyone actually enter the vault. Not until and unless they had the necessary clearance.

“Oh! I feel like Dr Jones! You know, movie with Harrison Ford, Han Solo, right?”

“Yeah, we know Indiana Jones,” the Colonel said.

This had to be an act. Sam was certain now.

“I have watched Star Wars fourteen times,” Teal’c said. “Han Solo is undoubtedly Harrison Ford’s best role.”

Dr Georgovich blinked. “Fourteen times?”

“It was thirteen times, but I found myself with time on my hand after our return from Etheria,” Teal’C replied.

When he had been sidelined by their superiors. Sam clenched her teeth for a moment - she didn’t support that decision. Teal’c had earned their trust over and over again.

And seemed to have confused the dear Dr Georgovich - a feat not even the Colonel had managed so far.

“Ah, I see.” The scientist blinked. “So… how many alien artefacts are in vault?”

“That’s classified,” the Colonel told him.

“I thought you were told to cooperate,” General Li said.

“Yes. Within limits set by the President himself.” The Colonel grinned widely. “You aren’t in our chain of command yet, and treating you as if you had the necessary clearance would be a grave breach of regulations.”

“Da!” Dr Georgovich smiled. “Very loyal, very obedient, yes! Good soldier follow orders, right?”

“Yeah…” The Colonel narrowed his eyes at the man, but the scientist was already talking to Sam again. “So, here is vault, but where is your lab? How do you work here? I am very curious about working conditions!”

“My lab is a level above this floor,” she told him.

“For safety? So not blow up both vault and lab, da?”

“Oh, Carter hasn’t blown up anything in ages - it should be pretty safe to enter her lab.”

That was too much! “Colonel!” she hissed under her breath.

He made an innocent face.

And Georgovich beamed again. “Ah, joke! I understand. Good joke!”

Sam turned to lead them to her lab, rolling her eyes as soon as she was facing away from their guests. What was with the Colonel? He couldn’t really be holding a grudge from the Cold War, could he?

They reached her lab after another short ride in the elevator.

“Oh. Very small. Not much room for pacing - do you not pace? I think best when pacing.”

Well, Sam hadn’t really expected that their guests would be impressed, but… this was a little rude.

“Think when relocating, get better lab. More spacious. And with bed and shower, in case you work late. Maybe kitchen and fridge, tto. Good idea?”

Sam blinked. That was actually a very good idea. She had lamented the lack of space in her lab a few times in the past. And to be able to sleep in the lab would save time in a crisis…

“Carter! Accepting a bribe is illegal!” The Colonel commented - she must have let her expression betray her thoughts.

“No crime!” Georgovich protested. “But scientists need space to work. No poaching - unless you feel like getting poached, of course!” He beamed at her. “We offer spacious lab and much better coffee!”

He was joking. Probably. But the Colonel was glaring as if this had been a serious attempt to recruit her.

“As things stand, most of Stargate Command will be transferred to the United Nations Stargate Command,” General Haig cut in. “But we will add both military and civilian staff. The scope of the operation has to expand, after all, now that we’re going to have a proper war.”

“‘A proper war’?” The Colonel narrowed his eyes at the General. “Sir?”

The British officer didn’t seem impressed at all. “Yes. So far, you’ve conducted the war through special operations. With the Etherians, this will change. We’ll be shifting to conventional warfare, with special operations in support of planetary invasions.”

“There will be independent operations as before,” General Sidorov said in accented English, “under control of the United Nations.”

“We will have to hash out with the Etherians how best to move troops and supplies,” General Haig went on. “But the Stargate will play an essential part of any invasion, I think.”

“You seem pretty confident that you will manage to negotiate an alliance with the Etherians,” the Colonel commented.

Sam had to agree - this sounded very optimistic to her.

“Shouldn’t we?” General Haig shrugged. “The conditions set by them can and will be easily fulfilled by Her Majesty’s Government.”

“Indeed,” General Dubois agreed with a smug smile, “full equality before the law for every citizen, no matter their sexual orientation, is certainly in line with the founding principles of the république. France is united in this.”

The Colonel pressed his lips together instead of answering at once. That wasn’t a good sign.

Daniel, though, spoke up: “But the Etherians expect more than lip service. They expect full commitment to ensuring that the laws you pass are enforced.”

General Haig was unfazed. “As I said, Her Majesty’s Government’s stance is that such conditions are easily fulfilled. Inquiries were made, and assurances received that the Etherians are aware that attitudes among some part of the population wouldn’t change overnight.”

The Colonel glanced at General Sidorov. “Equal rights by authoritarian decree should be a good trick. Especially after killing off the Tsar and his entire family.”

The Russian didn’t seem to let himself be baited. “That is a matter for politics. Even without an alliance with the Etherians, the

Stargate will be under the control of the United Nations, and exploration and diplomatic missions will continue - for the world."

Sam blinked. That sounded like…

"You want to keep us out of the war?" the Colonel blurted out.

"That's a question for the politicians," Sidorov replied. "But in order to wage war, we need an alliance or at least a way to coordinate with the Etherians."

"And with their allies," General Dubois interjected.

"We only know for sure that the Stargate will be under international control," General Li said. "but we remain optimistic that an agreement can be reached - in a war, compromises must be made, after all."

"Good luck getting the magical princesses to compromise," Sam heard the Colonel mutter next to her.

"In any case, we will do science!" Dr Georgovich spoke up again. "And in new, spacious lab!"

That would be a small consolation, in Sam's opinion, if Stargate Command ended up relegated from Earth's premier force facing the Goa'uld to some… guard and support unit for diplomatic missions. She wasn't arrogant, but SG-1 had the most experience in dealing with the Goa'uld. That kind of knowledge shouldn't be dismissed.

And she wanted to keep doing crucial work, a small voice in the back of her mind added. Especially now that she could publish her findings.

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Dulles International Airport, Washington DC, Earth, September 8th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“I agree with my colleague,” Brown said. “An interview is almost overdue. But you need to prepare extensively for your interview. And you need to pick your interviewer carefully. I would suggest CNN - the channel has a global reach and a good reputation.”

Catra suppressed a snort when she saw Adora nod eagerly - she’d already had to keep her lover from spending all night working out increasingly complicated relations between the most prominent journalists without even knowing who would be relevant - or what.

“They’re an American channel,” Gimmer pointed out. “And one that isn’t too popular in the conservative circles, as far as we could tell.”

“Yes.” Brown nodded. “But you hired me to improve your image with the American public, and picking a news service in the USA will play better with the conservative crowd. Though no matter their views, almost everyone will be watching CNN for your interview.”

“No pressure,” Bow mumbled with a grin, too low for anyone except for Glimmer, who was sitting very close to him, and Catra to hear.

She chuckled. Adora was fretting already about being watched by billions.

“Won’t that be resented by the other countries?” Entrapta asked, tilting her head.

“Not as long as you don’t wait too long with giving foreign news services interviews as well,” Brown told her. “And your image in most countries in Europe is better than in the USA, according to the latest poll we ran.”

“Oh! You’ve got new data?” Entrapta piped up.

Brown smiled. “I’ll send you a summary.”

“Thanks!”

“But now for your preparations. I don’t know what my colleague told you already, but there’s a whole science to presenting your best side on television. Elections were lost for bungling up a TV appearance,” Brown went on. “So, I would like to hire a specialist for the visual aspect of that.”

They still hadn’t hired more public relations consultants from other countries, but this sounded like a good idea. Catra glanced at her lover. Adora was already fretting too much about this as things were. If she had to sit through a few hours worrying over what to wear… “Good idea!” she said.

Bow stared at her. “You want a stylist working on you?”

Catra returned his stare with a frown. Why would that surprise him? “Why do you think I wouldn’t want that?” Granted, it was mostly for Adora, but it wouldn’t hurt her either.

“You’re always wearing the same clothes!” he blurted out.

So was he. “Did you forget Princess Prom?” she shot back.

He blinked, then nodded. “Ah.”

She rolled her eyes. She was wearing her old uniform so she had a reminder of… things she wanted but couldn’t allow herself to forget. Not because she thought it was the best outfit ever. And she wouldn’t beg for a new outfit.

“It’s more than styling, actually,” Brown spoke up. “It’s also about how to sit, move and talk, treat the camera, body language in general and, crucially, what pitfalls to avoid.

“Pitfalls?” Adora tensed.

“Verbal pitfalls - statements that might be misconstrued, phrases and their meaning in the United States, and such things. How you

say something is as important, sometimes more important, than what you say." Brown spread his hands. "It's a science."

Entrapta perked up. "Fascinating! Can we do experiments?"

Brown's smile slipped a tiny bit. "I think rehearsals would be mandatory, but I wouldn't experiment with public relations. Failures will have consequences."

"Oh." Entrapta blinked. "So, if we wanted to test a hypothesis, we would need to run an experiment without the test subjects being aware of our involvement. Although that might influence the results…"

Catra drew a breath through her clenched teeth. "Maybe wait with running social experiments until you have a better baseline?"

"You mean stick to passively gathering data?" Entrapta cocked her head. "I guess that would make sense. You need data to prepare a proper experiment, after all." She nodded with a smile. "I bet we'll get a lot of data from this!"

Brown wasn't the only wincing, Catra noted. But when it came to wrangling Entrapta, this was a good result.

She was a great friend and a very nice person, but she could scare you without meaning to.

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The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, September 7th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill was thoroughly sick of Dr Iwan the Terrible Comedian. His - absolutely fake! - accent grated on Jack's nerves, his constant smiling made Jack feel like he was about to be ambushed, and his subtle-as-a-brick-to-the-face attempts to poach Carter begged for some good old Cold War-style retaliation.

"...oh, what ingenious solution! Very Impressive, Dr Carter - I mean, Captain Carter. No wonder you are head scientist here."

"Thank you, Doctor."

"Call me Iwan, please - we are colleagues of sorts, yes?"

No, you are rivals. Rivals from rival powers, Jack thought.

But Carter didn't rebuke the man - she was just too polite to do the right thing. "Call me Samantha, then. Or Sam."

"Thank you! Which do you prefer?" The Russian spy was beaming again.

"I don't have any preference."

That was a lie. Jack was sure Carter had a preference.

"Samantha then. It is a beautiful name."

"Thank you."

"And speaking of names," Daniel cut in, finally making himself useful, "I noticed on your name tag that your name doesn't use the usual Russian spelling of 'Ivan'. Do you have German ancestry, perhaps?"

Asking a Russian if he was German? Jack winced.

But the man smiled at Daniel. "Ah, common assumption, yes, but mistaken. It is actually Welsh name."

Jack blinked. "Welsh?" he asked before he could help himself.

"Yes. Grandmother was from Cardiff."

So he was both British and Russian - that explained why he was doubly annoying.

But the man was still talking. “She was nurse in Spanish Civil War, fighting fascists, and met my grandfather, who was volunteer from Russia. Commissar, actually, but we don’t talk about that.”

Then why are you mentioning it? Jack thought. But both Daniel and Carter were listening attentively.

“So, they met, fell in love, and when fascists won despite best efforts, she went back with him to Russia. She was killed in Great Patriotic War but already had my father, also named Iwan. Family tradition of naming first son Iwan.”

“Ah.” Daniel looked torn between his curiosity and empathy. And Carter looked…

…entirely too sympathetic for Jack’s taste. The man’s grandfather had been a political commissar, for crying out loud! If they hadn’t killed more republicans than fascists in Spain, it hadn’t been for lack of effort!

“That is why I have been learning English. Too bad grandmother died before teaching father. I also hope to learn Welsh - perhaps after retirement.”

And there went Daniel. “Oh, it’s a fascinating language!”

“Da! But need to improve English more, to work together at Stargate! Fortunately, science is universal language, right? Especially mathematics.”

Carter smiled far too kindly at the man.

“Do not worry, O’Neill,” Teal’c said, sotto voce, as Carter showed Dr Iwan-the-Terrible the main gate control room, “Captain Carter is an honourable soldier and will not leave your service in the middle of a war.”

“Thanks, Teal’c,” Jack replied. “But I don’t think Carter would leave the team even if we weren’t at war with the Goa’uld.” At least he hoped so.

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded sagely, but there was a hint of a grin - or smirk - on his face.

Jack stared at him, but Teal’c had put up his usual inscrutable expression again.

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Dulles International Airport, Washington DC, Earth, September 10th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“...so, let the interviewer speak. Don’t interrupt them - even if you think you know what they are asking. And don’t lecture people. The public reacts negatively to presumed arrogance. Also, watch your body language like - exactly like that! Don’t do that on TV!” Melissa Barnaby, Brown’s ‘specialist’, pointed at Catra, who had her arms crossed over her chest and was frowning at her.

Adora suppressed a sigh. The woman certainly seemed to know her business - her advice about Earth fashion sounded very, well, sound. But Catra didn’t like to be told, well, that pretty much everything she did was wrong.

“I thought we also should be authentic,” Catra snapped. “And not act as if we were all sunshine and roses even when we’re talking to idiots.”

“You aren’t going to talk to idiots,” Melissa retorted. “Not unless you pick the wrong channel to give an interview.”

“So, make it ‘even when we’re faced with lies and questions from idiots they quote’ then,” Catra said with a sneer.

“Even then, you can’t lose your temper - that would leave a bad impression. You want to appear friendly. Firm in your stances but polite and respectful. No one likes a gloating jerk.”

“They seem to be very popular in media,” Glimmer pointed out.

“Jerks are popular in a certain crowd - if they are rude to people whom that crowd doesn’t like. So, yes, being rude and dismissive about conservatives will be popular in more liberal circles, but won’t make you more popular amongst conservatives,” Melissa replied. “And that’s your goal, isn’t it?”

Glimmer’s expression mirrored Catra’s.

Bow cleared his head. “But we shouldn’t put on an act,” he said. “We don’t want to lie to people to get them to like us.”

Adora nodded emphatically. “We want to be honest.”

“Besides, I’m already being nicer than usual if I don’t scratch an idiot,” Catra added with a scoff, flexing her claws.

Melissa blinked.

Adora quickly said. “Catra’s kidding.” She added a glare at her lover to ensure that this was true.

Catra nodded with a pout. “Unless they attack us, I won’t touch them.”

“You won’t be attacked in a studio,” Melissa told her.

“I wouldn’t be so sure,” Catra retorted. “I’ve organised an attack at a ball.”

Melissa blinked.

“Stop sounding so proud about it!” Glimmer snapped.

Adora sighed.

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“What’s wrong with my uniform?” Adora asked a short explanation and a quick assessment of her wardrobe later. “It’s comfortable and sturdy.” And it held a lot of memories.

“But it’s rather plain,” Melissa said. “The cuts in the sleeves are a nice style element, but the shoulders are a bit over the top. Overall, it lacks a certain something.”

“Something what?” Adora frowned.

“Something that says ‘I’m an alien magical princess and I’m here to help you’ without being too in your face about it. No tiara, but…” Melissa took a step to the side and eyed Adora’s hair. “...maybe a change of style there as well.”

Adora resisted the urge to put a hand on top of her hairdo. She liked her hairstyle just as it was!

Catra snorted, and Adora glared at her - her lover’s hairstyle had been deemed ‘passable’ already.

“What about a bare midriff?” Bow asked. Melissa narrowed her eyes at him, and he recoiled.

“That would not go over well at all with your target crowd.”

“Are you sure?” Entrapta chimed in. “A lot of your media popular with conservatives feature such outfits rather prominently.” She showed a picture of a woman in shorts and a knotted shirt in front of an orange car on her tablet. “See?”

Melissa sighed. “You don’t want to be likened to such characters, trust me - that would sabotage your image.”

“Ah.” Entrapta frowned. “Is this an example of them liking something but pretending not to like it because it goes against a dominant part of their culture?”

“No, that’s an example of conservative sexism. If you appear like that on television, they won’t take you seriously at all,” Melissa said.

Bow looked taken aback. “They won’t?” He stared at his midriff.

Melissa sighed again. “It’s different in your case.”

“Homophobes! I got data about them!” Entrapta smiled. “Most of them will be attracted to you, Bow, but they will try to deny and suppress their feelings.”

Bow grimaced. “I’m not sure if I should be flattered or alarmed.”

“Alarmed. Definitely alarmed,” Melissa said. “But we can work with your style - but it’s not for everyone else.”

“Aw! I bet Adora would rock that look!” Catra crowed.

Adora felt herself blush in response. She cleared her throat. “Anyway, we have been seen on television already. Shouldn’t we stick with our, ah, image?” The Earth leaders basically always wore the same suits anyway, right?

Melissa nodded. “But a few touch-ups would greatly improve your image. You might even set a new trend. Or rather, you’ll boost an already starting trend.”

“Well, Glimmer, you can put your royal coronation outfit on,” Adora suggested.

“That’s just my cape,” Glimmer replied.

“It still looks nice and, uh, regal?” Adora tilted her head with a forced smile.

“We should stick you into your prom dress,” Catra said.

“But it’s not a ball,” Entrapta protested. “Or is it? I’m still working on gathering data on Earth social conventions.”

Melissa sighed once more.

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Pentagon, Washington DC, Earth, September 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter wished she had a spaceship. Or a working ring transporter. It would make the trips to Washington to brief generals and politicians more bearable. Since there hasn't been a C-37 available today, and commercial flights had been deemed not safe enough, she'd had to hitch a ride on a C-130 today. That hadn't been comfortable enough to work efficiently and had taken much longer than a spaceship would have. And all for a briefing she could have done remotely through a video conference, anyway - and she had refuted the Pentagon's security concerns thoroughly in her latest report, which apparently had been ignored.

'Ours is not to reason why', as Daniel would quote if she complained to him. And that was why she was here for what the Colonel would call 'a complete waste of time'. At least she had been able to catch up on paperwork on the flight.

"No, Sir, I don't think handing the spare Stargate over to the United Nations is a workable solution," she repeated herself. They had gone over this already, back when it had first been proposed as a response to the demands from the Security Council. There was a reason everyone was busy planning to make the takeover of Stargate Command go through with the least amount of friction.

"I wasn't talking about diplomatic issues, Captain." The Army general who had asked her about it frowned at her. "We called you here for technical advice."

"And I am talking about the technical aspects," she retorted. "As my report about this stated, running two Stargates in one location - on one planet - creates interference since both use the same gate address." A report she had written shortly after discovering the second gate through this very effect, which had ended with herself and the Colonel getting stuck in an ice cave in the Antarctic. "We would end up with multiple misconnections - and possibly fatalities from our defences."

“Thank you. We didn’t call you here to discuss that, anyway,” the Chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff said, shutting up the obnoxious general with a glare. “There is talk about relocating the Stargate to a more accessible location, either in Canada or Australia.”

Ah. She nodded - Iwan had told them about that. Russia’s proposal to use Siberia had apparently been rejected despite, as he claimed, their great experience with ‘building entire research centres and bases in the middle of nowhere so expected accidents do not hurt civilians.’

“So, we would like your assessment of the proposed locations from a technical point of view,” the Chairman went on.

Did they expect her to give an assessment of the logistical issues without any time to study said locations in detail? Sam almost shook her head. “As long as the power requirements for the operation of the Stargate are met and there is enough space to house the equipment and staff, any location will be suitable for running Stargate Command, as far as the technical aspect is concerned,” she said. “Unlike with satellite launches, location provides no inherent benefit or drawback.” And with alien technology, the advantage of being closer to the equator for launches would vanish as well.

“That would require a large power plant,” another general said. “A very large power plant.”

“Yes, Sir.”

“Are there alternatives to such a plant?” he asked.

“The DHD the Russians recovered could fuel the Stargate independently, but its capacity is limited,” she said. “Enough for the average use of a Stargate, but not enough to power it for constant high-volume traffic. Its recovery rate is not high enough, and we haven’t yet managed to duplicate its power generation method.” Not for lack of trying on her part.

“Ah.”

“Etherian technology would offer compact alternatives - compact compared to a conventional power plant, not a DHD,” she went on.

She noted that several Generals frowned or even winced. The Chairman nodded, though. “That would require their support.”

“Yes, Sir.” She nodded emphatically. If any of the people present thought the United States could accomplish this without outside help, they hadn’t read her reports at all.

“Wonderful,” the Army general who had asked her about the second Stargate muttered. “More leverage for them.”

“Speaking of the Etherians,” an admiral spoke up, “did they voice any preference or resistance to specific locations or climates?”

Catra didn’t like the ocean, but Sam didn’t think that was relevant here. “Based on their references to events during their war, I think they would prefer to avoid arctic climates as well as deserts.”

“We can plant our Stargate where we damn well want,” the first general muttered again.

“You mean where the Security Council wants it,” the admiral corrected him. “Canada would be much closer to us - and to Europe. Wherever this gate is installed will become a hub for the entire planet. It needs a good harbour - we’ll want to base a fleet there to protect the shipping.”

“A space fleet,” another general - Air Force - added with a smirk.

The admiral frowned at him. “I do not think cargo ships will be replaced by spaceships any time soon, at least on Earth. And by the time space cargo ships are common, the Navy will have adapted.”

“What?” The Air Force general glared at him. “Space is clearly the domain of the Air Force!”

“Only as long as it was about satellite reconnaissance. If anyone has the experience to run a ship, it’s the Navy. You can’t run a ship, or a spaceship, as if it were a plane!”

“Oh, yeah? Just watch us!”

Sam refrained from rolling her eyes or otherwise showing her reaction. They still hadn’t made much progress forming an alliance with the Etherians, and the Navy and the Air Force brass were already squabbling over who got to run a hypothetical fleet in space?

They needed to get their priorities straight!

Besides, it was clear that the Air Force had the most experience here.

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The Interview Part 2

Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Oh, my! I never expected to do an interview in space!"

Catra raised her eyebrows at the outburst from the CNN journalist.

Mr Pullmann - he hadn't asked them to call him Bob, unlike in his latest interview - stared through the windows on Darla's bridge, shaking his head before he turned to face them. "You know, it looks exactly like on the picture I've seen, but it's so different if you're seeing it in person."

"Really? That is weird," Entrapta spoke up. "Are you sure that this isn't just an emotional bias?"

Pullmann blinked. "Ah… Actually, that is what I was talking about."

"Ah! So it wasn't because of inferior optics." Entrapta nodded, satisfied, then turned around and started to dictate her findings into her device.

Pullman blinked again.

Glimmer cleared her throat. "So, do you want to do the interview on the bridge or in the lounge?"

"We would also offer the hold, but it's also serving as our laboratory, so that's not going to work well," Entrapta added, looking up and letting her hair handle her device.

That didn't seem to unnerve Mr Pullmann, Catra noted - he had prepared for this, of course. Or had been prepared. That made her wonder if his awe at the sight of space was an act as well.

“I think the bridge will do nicely. The throne makes for a nice background,” he replied.

“Throne?” Glimmer frowned.

Catra chuckled. “That’s not a throne. That’s the Captain’s Chair.”

“Yes!” Entrapta piped up. “Darla is She-Ra’s ship, and when Mara, Adora’s predecessor, was in control of it, she wasn’t a Princess. Well, as far as we know - there probably were princesses back then, but we don’t have any definite records about She-Ra’s status. Especially since Mara was a foreigner.”

“Oh.” Pullman nodded. “I know you should never ask a lady about her age, but… how old is Darla?”

“About a thousand years, give or take a century,” Entrapta replied as Pullmann’s eyebrows rose. “But we completely restored her and brought her up to modern standards.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “Darla’s the equal of any other ship in her class now.”

Catra knew Darla was now actually better than any other ship in her class that they knew about, but there was no need to share that information. So she shrugged. “She still looks ancient, of course. But I doubt that we could fool anyone like we did in the war.”

Pullman, as expected, perked up at that. “Maybe we could talk about that during the interview?”

“Of course,” Adora said. “Although you’ll understand that we can’t go into every detail - we’re still at war.”

“Oh. Do you expect there to be more alien spies on Earth?”

“It’s just good practice not to share potentially crucial intel,” Catra told him.

“Loose lips sink spaceships, huh?” He smiled.

“Something like that,” Glimmer said. “Although usually, it’s Sea Hawk who sinks ships.”

“And sings,” Catra added.

Pullman frowned just a little but didn’t ask who Sea Hawk was. Too bad - Catra would have loved explaining.

“So, let’s start?” Adora said. “What about the Earth as a background?” she pointed at the seats lining the wall below the window. Just as Melissa had suggested.

“It’s your ship,” Pullman replied.

“Then let’s get set up,” Adora said. “We have the camera prepared.”

“It should be compatible with your system - just from watching your program, we didn’t hack your systems to check,” Entrapta said. “But once you upgrade to full holographic projections, you can use the recording for that as well.”

“Ah. Good to know - although that will probably take a while. No one in the United States, or on Earth, has a holographic system,” Pullman said.

“Well, that should change once you start upteching. Until then, you could run both systems in parallel - I thought about a way to do that if you’re interested in some outlines.”

Adora coughed.

“Oops. Sorry - we didn’t start the interview, and I’m already questioning you instead of the other way around. Sorry!” Entrapta beamed at him.

Pullman smiled. “Oh, no - I like it when an interview feels more like a discussion than an interrogation.”

"Oh, yes. In a discussion, people don't get annoyed if you keep slipping out of your cuffs."

And there he was confused again. Catra still wasn't entirely sure that including Entrapta in the interview was a good idea, but it seemed to be working for them so far.

"So, let's take our seats," Adora said. "The camera's here."

"I wanted Emily to record it, but she doesn't fit into the bridge," Entrapta added. "Emily's my best bot. She's a modified assault bot with reinforced armour plate and a stronger blaster. I'll introduce you after the interview."

Pullmann's smile didn't slip, but his eyebrows rose again. "I'm looking forward to it."

And then they sat down. Adora and Glimmer in the middle, flanked by Catra and Bow, with Entrapta on Bow's other side and Hordak next to her. And Melog next to Catra.

"So, we're here, floating above Earth," Pullman started, "in Darla, Princess She-Ra's personal spaceship. And I think everyone knows Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, She-Ra, Princess of Power, Queen Entrapta of Dryl, Catra, Bow, and Hordak. And Melog. I'm Bob Pullman, for CNN."

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The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, September 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and I'm just saying - the Marine Corps has the experience when it comes to landing operations and boarding ships. We're the obvious choice to expand into space-based landing operations and security on spaceships."

Jack O'Neill rolled his eyes as he stepped into the lift - he could do that; he was a Colonel, Warren was a Major. And the commander of SG-3 was a Marine. Of course he'd claim that the Marines were

the first choice to go into space. “No one has any experience with space-based landing operations,” he replied.

“But the fundamentals are the same - we’re used to living on ships for lengths of time, landing on hostile shores… the Army isn’t used to that.”

Jack shook his head. “It’s not the same. Space is different.” Otherwise, might as well let the Navy take over.

“Really? And you’re not just saying this because the Navy’s trying to take over space-based forces from the Air Force?” Warren asked.

Jack snorted. “It’s the same for them - they have no experience in space.”

“But they have experience with submarines. Which are pretty close to spaceships.”

That was a good argument, actually. But Jack would be damned if he’d let such a thing influence him when it came to defending Air Force turf. “Stargate Command is an Air Force program - we’ve got the most experience with aliens, alien technology, other planets - you name it, we did it.”

“I recall SG-3 being Marines,” Warren retorted.

“You’re honorary Air Force.” Jack grinned at Warren’s scowl. “But yes, in a pinch, I’d take the Corps over the Army. You’re more used to operating on a thin supply line.”

“Good. This is going to be bloody. Very bloody,” Warren said. “I’ve got calls from every officer I know or have heard of about Stargate Command. And I’ve been called in for a meeting with the top brass.”

Jack snorted. “Of course it’s going to be bloody. The service that gets to control the American space forces will dominate the armed forces. The Navy is looking at becoming obsolete in short order.”

Once spaceships were on the horizon, the Navy would lose all relevance - who wanted or needed aircraft carriers if you had spaceships? Or missile cruisers? Or destroyers?

"They will suffer so many cuts, the Coast Guard will have a bigger budget," Warren said.

Jack chuckled. Served the Navy pukes right.

"On the other hand, if they get to expand into space, the Air Force's done for," Warren went on.

Jack clenched his teeth to avoid cursing. Warren was correct - if the Navy became the space force, they would get all the shiny new space fighters. The Air Force would lose out - hell, they might even get folded back into the Army, to provide close air support and transport or something. "That won't happen," he said. "We've got both the Space Command and Stargate Command. We've got too much experience." And personal contacts with the Etherians. "You'd have to be an idiot to throw that away."

"That never stopped Washington," Warren said. "And Space Command? Really?"

Jack shrugged. General Naird and his bunch of nerds didn't have any real experience with aliens or combat, being glorified satellite handlers. But they were Air Force Space Command. And with Stargate Command apparently being put under United Nations control, the Air Force needed every little bit of help.

They reached their floor - the canteen. Where the television would be showing the first-ever interview with the Etherians. Warren and Jack entered and moved to the front, where Daniel waved. "I saved us a table!" he said.

"I'll be sitting with my guys," Warren said, nodding and walking over to SG-3 in the corner.

Jack sighed as he sat down. "So… what are the pundits saying about this?"

Daniel shrugged. “Mostly nothing.”

“But in many, many words.” Jack chuckled.

“Indeed,” Teal’c agreed. “Their use of words was very inefficient.”

“That’s because they are paid to talk,” Carter said.

Jack nodded. “And if they don’t talk at length whenever they can, people might question their salaries.” But he didn’t want to discuss budgets again. “So… does anyone have the inside scoop?” He looked at Daniel and Carter.

“No,” Daniel said. “I know they’ve been preparing for this with consultants, but that’s all.”

“Entrapta sounded quite optimistic about their preparations,” Carter added.

“Well, it’s not live at least,” Jack said. “So, whatever is being broadcast won’t be too bad.”

His friends didn’t seem to share his optimism. “CNN won’t accept too much editing,” Daniel said. “If they accept any at all.”

Carter nodded. “Entrapta didn’t mention anything about final approval.”

Great. Jack wished the canteen would serve alcohol. He had a feeling that he’d need a stiff drink soon.

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Earth Orbit, Earth, Solar System, September 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“It’s starting!”

Adora couldn’t help feeling that Catra sounded far too cheerful about this. Or far too confident about the interview. Adora didn’t share that confidence. She was sure she had done something

wrong. Mr Brown had been a bit… diplomatic after watching the recording. And Julie had been terse. And Melissa had stuck to comments about their body language, makeup and clothes. But if it was truly bad, wouldn't they have said something? Or kept Entrapta from handing the recording over to Mr Pullman?

"Good!" Entrapta, of course, was happy as ever as she used her hair to lift her over the back of the couch she had installed in the hold and plopped down in front of the huge television screen she had constructed for the occasion. "I made popcorn since I was told that that is the traditional meal to eat while watching this!"

"I think popcorn is for watching entertainment," Bow commented as he took a seat on the second couch.

"This certainly should be entertaining," Catra said. "Come on, Adora! It's starting!"

Adora glanced at Glimmer, who sighed, obviously also not as confident as the rest of them, and joined her lover on the third couch.

Hordak, carrying a huge tray loaded with Earth drinks of all kinds - Adora wondered if he needed his armour's servos to lift it - arrived just as the logo on the screen faded, and they saw a studio with Mr Pullmann seated behind a big desk.

"Good evening, America! I'm Bob Pullman," he said - even though his name also appeared in a small band at the bottom of the screen, *"and I'm here to present the first in-depth interview with our visitors from the planet Etheria."*

"So they did count the questions we were asked in Switzerland as an interview!" Entrapta nodded.

"Not necessarily," Hordak retorted. "They might just want to stress the personal aspect."

"Shhh!" Bow hissed. "It's starting!"

And indeed, once more, the screen changed - this time to a view of Darla's bridge, every one of them lined up, with Earth visible behind them and Mr Pullman on the right side, facing them. And their names and titles appeared below them on the screen.

"Queen Glimmer, Princess She-Ra, Princess Entrapta, Mr Bow, Miss Catra, Mr Hordak, Melog, thank you for granting me an interview. I am aware that you are terribly busy with politics and the war, and I appreciate that you made time to answer the questions of the public." Mr Pullman nodded with a smile.

"Oh, think nothing of it!" Adora said. "We appreciate the opportunity to explain more about ourselves. You should never blindly trust people, after all, right?"

Adora winced. Her smile looked forced - but she had been so nervous!

"Honesty is the best policy, or so you said, right?" Mr Pullman asked.

"Yes!"

"I don't want to pry, but that sounds as if this stems from personal experience." The man leaned forward with an earnest expression on his face.

"Ah… Yes, we've had experiences with betrayal and lies." Adora nodded earnestly. As did Catra, although with a scowl on her face.

"But also with misunderstandings based on a lack of reliable data!" Entrapta piped up - she was sitting on the edge of her seat, her hair moving around her. "Once I thought I had been abandoned in the war, but my friends thought I had been killed, so they didn't send a rescue mission while I was waiting."

"Oh?" Mr Pullman tilted his head, eyebrows raising. "That sounds like a harrowing experience, But you obviously survived."

"Yes! And I met Hordak and Catra through it!" Entrapta replied. "Although I had met Catra before, at the Princess Prom."

"Which is a ball for all the Princesses and Princes of Etheria, held every ten years," Glimmer cut in. "It is the most important event in international politics and diplomacy."

Adora saw herself reaching over and squeezing Catra's thigh before her lover could say that she had blown it up. Catra might be doing it because she still felt guilty about it or because she liked to grandstand or a bit of both, but this wasn't the time for either.

"Which brings us to the first topic. Etheria." Mr Pullman nodded. "It is a planet ruled by princes and princesses, right?"

"Yes," Glimmer told him. "There are over a hundred kingdoms of various sizes."

"And you're the queen."

"The traditional title for the ruler of Bright Moon is Queen," she said. "But that doesn't mean I have a higher rank than Princess Entrapta. We're both sovereign rulers of our respective kingdoms."

"Yes! Although Dryl is much smaller than Bright Moon, and I'm not an Elemental Princess," Entrapta cut in. "My magic power is my prehensible hair while the Elemental Princesses control the elements - well, after a fashion."

"But we're all equal in the Alliance," Glimmer said.

"Speaking of equality," Mr Pullman spoke up again. "You are undoubtedly aware that on Earth, absolute monarchies are very rare nowadays. Most countries are democracies. Are there any democracies on Etheria?"

"Not really," Bow spoke up. "Not on a kingdom level, at least. Many villages elect their leader or mayor, but that's often the son or daughter of the previous leader. And of course, pirates elect

their captains, but I don't think they count." He grinned before growing serious again. "The rule of princesses and princes goes back to before the Age of War and has never been seriously challenged on Etheria. Part of the reason for that is, of course, tradition at this point, but in the past, it was likely based on the fact that all princesses and princes have a magic talent."

"That sounds as if it would be very difficult to replace a princess with a democratically elected representative," Mr Pullman said.

"Well, certain kingdoms do rely on the magical power of their ruler. Like Mermista's control over the Seagate, which keeps Salineas safe. Or Perfuma's control over plants, which feeds her kingdom," Bow said.

"Two kingdoms, actually, since the Fright Zone still needs her help," Glimmer said.

"Ah. So, if people would turn against their princess, they would lose their help?"

"Yes," Hordak said without hesitation. "Not unlike the Earth custom of granting special privileges to the rich in the hope that they will share their money with the poor, I believe."

Mr Pullman's smile grew a bit blander in response, and he leaned forward. "Do you think that the position of rich people on Earth is comparable to princesses on Etheria?"

Hordak looked as if he didn't understand the question. "I just said that, didn't I?"

"Yes, you did." Mr Pullman nodded.

"It's similar," Adora spoke up. "As a princess, you have responsibilities. You have power but also a duty to use it well. Especially as a ruling princess. You have to protect and help those who need it."

"Noblesse oblige?" Mr Pullman asked. "Privilege entails responsibility?" He smiled. "With great power comes great responsibility?"

"Of course!" Glimmer agreed, nodding emphatically. "That is what the princess alliance is all about."

"It's also a defence pact," Hordak added.

"Yes," Glimmer told him, looking a little annoyed. "But at its core, it's about using your power to protect your people - and everyone else."

"Let's come back to the comparison of princesses to rich people on Earth," Mr Pullman said. "Or, to be precise, to rich people. Do you need to be a princess to be rich on Etheria? How does the economy work?"

"That depends on how you define 'rich'," Bow replied. "There are many merchants and other people who are wealthy, but the differences between them and the other people aren't as large as on Earth." He frowned. "As far as the economy goes… I'm not an expert, that would be my brother, Count, but Etheria has a much smaller economy. And it's not quite as industrialised."

"Yes," Catra chimed in. "The Horde's factories were a major advantage in the war. The Alliance couldn't match their production."

"We did pretty well in blowing up the tanks and bots," Glimmer said with a toothy smile.

"Only once She-Ra appeared," Catra shot back.

Bow coughed. "Anyway, one difference I spotted is that more of the economy is run by the kingdoms. There are lots of farmers and artisans, but most of the big projects are controlled by the princesses and princes."

"A state-controlled economy?"

"Of course," Hordak spoke up again. "How could you efficiently run a kingdom if you didn't have control over its production? Salineas would have fallen far sooner if they had been producing merchantmen instead of warships during the war."

"That sounds like a planned economy," Mr Pullman said. "That was attempted on Earth a few times, but with mixed results."

"You probably lacked the data to properly plan," Entrapta said. "That happened to me a few times - I had built so many bots, I couldn't use all of them. And the Horde ran into supply issues when it built too many tanks and not enough transports."

"Oh. You're talking about a war economy," Mr Pullman said.

"Yes?" Adora tilted her head. "We are at war, after all. Well, we were recovering from the war against the Horde when we heard about the Goa'uld, but we were quickly back on a war footing."

"Something Earth hasn't done," Catra added. "Despite being at war with the Goa'uld."

"Well, we weren't even aware of being at war with them," Mr Pullman replied. "Most of Earth, at least."

"Yeah, we were very surprised when we heard that," Entrapta said. "But now that you know, you can spin up war production!"

"That's for the government to decide," Mr Pullman told her. "But let's talk about the war some more. You were fighting the Horde on Etheria for decades, or so I've heard."

"Yes," Glimmer said. "My parents were founding members of the Princess Alliance. That was before I was born, after the Horde had taken over the Scorpion Kingdom and started its conquest of Etheria."

"It was the first such alliance since the Age of War," Bow added. "And the largest in recorded history. There were temporary alliances since then, but none involving so many princesses."

"And it barely managed to slow down our advance at the start," Hordak said. "Despite my preparations having been, in hindsight, insufficient."

"You mean you underestimated us," Glimmer retorted.

"Pardon me," Mr Pullman said. "But you fought each other?"

"I created and led the Horde on Etheria!" Hordak said. "I introduced its technology to Etheria - although since I was alone and had to rebuild my tech base by myself, my means were limited."

"Which was a very good thing," Bow quickly said. "Otherwise, you might have conquered Etheria for Horde Prime."

Hordak scowled. "Yes, as it turned out, I was misguided. Manipulated and exploited."

"You weren't the only one," Catra said.

"But it all worked out in the end!" Entrapta patted Hordak's thigh with her hand. "We came together and beat Horde Prime!"

"Yes," Adora said, nodding emphatically. "Once Horde Prime's fleet arrived, everyone fought him, and we won."

"You allied with former enemies? Even the leader of the Horde?" Mr Pullman sounded surprised.

"I was the leader of the Horde on Etheria. Until Horde Prime made it very clear that there was only one leader in the entire Horde - himself. And that we others were merely vessels for his will." Hordak scowled. "He tried to wipe out my consciousness, but I defied him."

"And you beat him," Entrapta said.

"Adora did kill him," Catra pointed out.

"We all worked together," Adora said. "And yes, we took in everyone who wanted to change. I was a former Horde soldier myself."

"You were a cadet. You never led the Horde," Catra cut in. "I did."

"You got better," Adora shot back. After a moment, both of them laughed.

Mr Pullman looked… very surprised.

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The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, September 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter suppressed a groan while on the screen, Adora started to explain how they grew up and how they 'split up temporarily', with Catra making snarky remarks.

The Colonel didn't hold back. "For Crying out loud!" he muttered. "Why did their consultants let that go through?"

"Probably because if they tried to hide that, it would have been revealed anyway, possibly at the worst moment?" Daniel speculated. "You know that Adora isn't the best at hiding something like that."

Or anything. Sam agreed with the assessment. Anyone expecting Adora to hide anything about her relationship with Catra was a fool. "I concur."

"Yeah, yeah, she's all for being honest - but I bet that 'reformed conquering warlords' wasn't the public image the Etherians were aiming for," the Colonel said.

Teal'c tilted his head. "Why would they not aim for such a revelation? As I was told, and have seen on television, the people of the United States love repenting sinners."

The Colonel winced. “Yeah, but repenting sinners usually don’t joke about their sins. Not on television, at least. They do that repenting thing.”

Sam had to agree.

“...and then we saved her and returned to Etheria to fight Horde Prime,” Adora finished her - quite edited, Sam knew - story.

“Now that’s a story!” Pullman was smiling widely again. “So, not only did you recruit former enemies during the war, but after you won, you incorporated them into your countries?”

“Not quite,” Glimmer spoke up. “Scorpia restored her kingdom, the Scorpion Kingdom, that the Horde had turned into the Fright Zone. And she decided to join the Alliance.”

“She decided to join Perfuma,” Catra commented with a grin.

Adora frowned. “I am sure that Scorpia would have joined the Alliance even if she weren’t together with Perfuma. It was a sound decision, given her experiences.”

“Well, you said that she defected during the war on Etheria. But what about the Horde soldiers who didn’t defect to the Alliance during the war?” Pullman asked. “Weren’t you concerned about what they would do - and what they had done?”

“If they want to change they still deserve a second chance,” Adora said. “Everyone deserves the chance to change. Just because you made mistakes in the past doesn’t mean you should be damned forever.”

“And there weren’t many die-hard Horde soldiers - most of their troops defected before the end,” Glimmer replied. “Horde Prime made it clear that he didn’t really care for anyone but himself. Not at all. Not even for his clones.”

“Yes,” Hordak said. “And with Horde Prime dead, my brothers were, for the first time in their lives, free to make their own

decisions. So it was easy to recruit them."

"We didn't 'recruit' them," Adora protested. "They joined us because of WrongHordak and Priest."

"WrongHordak was our first friend from the Horde," Entrapta explained. "We saved him when we saved Catra. Priest saw She-Ra eradicate Horde Prime and decided to worship her. And many followed his example."

"When you say 'worship', what exactly do you mean?" Pullman asked.

"Uh… exactly, that, worship?" Adora said with a strained smile.

"They consider her a goddess," Catra added with a smirk.

"I didn't ask for it! And denying it doesn't work!"

"And this 'Priest' would be in command of the ships currently orbiting Earth?" Pullman's smile looked fake now.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "And the rest of the Fleet currently stationed outside the Solar System. We didn't want to scare you accidentally by bringing all the ships. And their numbers might distort the night sky, which might affect the work of your astronomers."

"I see." Pullman nodded. "And, speaking of space and war fleets, you first heard of the Goa'uld when a team from Earth accidentally landed on your planet, right?"

"Well, they arrived through a Stargate, so they didn't technically land, but yes," Entrapta said.

"You'd never heard of them before?"

"Melog did," Catra said, pointing at the big cat next to her seat. "Their people knew them and what they were. We almost fought SG-1 because they felt the larva inside Teal'c."

Sam winced, and the Colonel cursed. That hadn't been widely known yet. Teal'c wasn't showing any reaction, but Daniel looked worried.

"Teal'c?" Pullman asked.

"Yes." Adora nodded. "He defected from the Goa'uld and joined Stargate Command."

"And he carries a Goa'uld inside him?" Pullman was leaning forward.

"Yes, a larva. That's how the Goa'uld breed, you know," Entrapta explained. "They put a larva inside one of their Jaffa, where it grows over several years until it is mature, at which point it gets a host, usually a human, and the Jaffa gets a new larva. The Jaffa depend on the larva for their immune system, you know? I would have thought that that was a defect, but the Goa'uld made the Jaffa that way so they had to stay loyal." She frowned. "They could have had their loyalty just by being nicer, I think."

"That sounds… horrible, actually," Pullman said.

"Yes! Not only do they enslave people, but they also use them as hosts, trapping them in their own bodies, and treat their soldiers as slaves and incubators." Glimmer nodded with a grim expression. "They are as bad as Horde Prime was. As soon as we heard about them, we knew we had to fight them."

"Yes," Adora agreed. "Such evil can't be tolerated. They already oppress countless people and they want to conquer everyone else - and they have destroyed worlds like Horde Prime did."

"Not on the same scale or using the same means," Entrapa added, "but for the dead people it works out the same, I think."

"So you think everyone needs to fight the Goa'uld?"

"Of course," Adora said. "If you don't fight them, they'll destroy you. They'll wreck your cities, kill your people and raise your

children as their brainwashed slaves. Together, we can beat them and free their slaves!"

"That seems logical." Pullman nodded. "Although something seems a little strange. If the Goa'uld are such a threat, and you're used to working with former enemies, why are you so hesitant to form an alliance with Earth? Or at least with the United States, since you've been working with Stargate Command for a while already?"

Sam winced again. She was certain that many Americans wouldn't like the answer.

*****

Earth Orbit, Earth, Solar System, September 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Now comes the best part!" Catra grinned. Adora groaned, and Catra patted her arm. "Honesty is the best policy, right?"

On the screen, Adora raised her chin with that adorably determined expression of hers. "That actually ties back to our history. When Hordak was stranded on Etheria, he was welcomed by the Scorpion Kingdom and taken in as a shipwrecked stranger. And in a few years, he had taken over the kingdom, turned it into the Fright Zone and started to conquer Etheria."

"It wasn't quite as simple," Hordak cut in. "The rulers of the Scorpion Kingdom didn't just take me in out of the goodness of their hearts - the princesses were interested in my technology. Especially my weapons. Without their support, I couldn't have formed the industrial base for the Horde on Etheria."

"I'm sure they didn't want to conquer Etheria," Glimmer said.

"But a little border adjustment?" Catra grinned.

"Anyway!" Adora raised her voice a little. "We want to limit our technology to countries that we can trust not to abuse our help to

conquer their neighbours - or attack us."

"And you don't trust the United States?" Pullman raised his eyebrows. "Your actions with Stargate Command seem to indicate a close relationship."

"We trust SG-1," Adora replied. "They're our friends. But that doesn't mean we trust everyone else in their country." She wrapped an arm around Catra's shoulders. "I mean… they wouldn't have let us into the army just because we love each other! How can you trust a country with such… such…"

"...such prejudices," Bow finished for her. He nodded with a serious expression. "I have two Dads. That wouldn't be possible in your country - it would be illegal. They couldn't marry. They couldn't have my siblings or me."

"But that doesn't mean that the USA would turn on you - the United States isn't in the business of enforcing their own morals on others," Pullman retorted. "Least of all their allies. Just look at Saudi Arabia or Kuwait."

"Well, a lot of your people seem to disagree," Glimmer said with a frown. "They call for our murder." She shook her head. "Yes, they are supposed to be a minority - but what kind of ruler would tolerate such demands when trying to form an alliance? What kind of ruler would let his subjects plot their supposed allies' death?"

"And it's not just the hostility - it's the insanity of it," Catra added. "We haven't done anything to them. Just because Adora and I are in love…" She blushed a little. "...apparently is enough of a reason for them to demand that we should be killed."

"Yes!" Adora nodded emphatically. "It's so insane! Completely crazy! What does it matter if we're both women? We love each other! We want to be happy together! Perhaps… form a family sometime in the future!" She blushed. "Just like everyone else! Why would that be wrong? We're not harming anyone!"

"We're not trying to 'make people gay'," Bow added with a scowl. "We're not telling anyone to stop loving their partner or partners."

"Unlike your people," Catra added.

Pullman frowned at that. "Well, as you said yourself, those people calling for violence are a tiny minority…"

Catra snorted. "A minority who can legally plan our death in your country."

"That's not entirely correct. Actually planning a murder is illegal."

"But telling others to murder people isn't against your law. Marrying your love is, though - if they're the same gender as yours." Glimmer crossed her arms over her chest. "That sounds insane to me."

"We just want the same as everyone else," Adora repeated herself: "Being happy with our love. Why are so many people against that? Why should that be illegal?"

Pullman cleared his throat. "Well, many of the more conservative people in the United States - and elsewhere - think same-sex relationships are immoral."

"Why?" Entrapta leaned forward. "There has to be a reason for that. Murder is wrong because you kill innocent people. Stealing is wrong because you take what isn't yours. Conducting experiments with new high-explosives in your laboratory instead of in the desert or a bunker is wrong because you risk hurting others in the castle if something goes wrong." She nodded. "But who would get hurt if my friends marry each other?"

Pullman didn't like those questions, Catra thought, but he was back to smiling politely. "Well, some people think that allowing such marriages would encourage such marriages - and would set an example for impressionable teenagers."

Catra snorted. "You don't want your people to have loving relationships and families?"

"A lot of the conservatives in the United States consider same-sex relationships a sin. They don't want people to sin. Or be tempted to sin."

"That makes no sense," Entrapta said.

"Would they rather have their family be unhappy?" Bow asked. "Why would it matter if you have two Dads or two Moms, or a Mom and a Dad? What matters is whether or not you love your family and care for them! And that doesn't depend on your gender!"

Pullman cleared his throat. "Well, as I said, those who advocate for violence are a tiny minority, and those who think your relationships should be illegal are also a minority according to our last polls."

"If they're a minority, why can't you change the laws? That's how democracy works, right? The majority sets the laws!" Catra said, staring at Pullman. "So, if you can't actually change your laws, doesn't that mean that those people aren't a minority?"

"And that is why you fear they would turn on you?" Pullman asked.

"It's one of the reasons," Glimmer replied. "How can we trust people who hate us just because we're not following their religion? People who are trying to force their views on others by outlawing relationships they don't like? If they're willing to force everyone like us in your country to be unhappy, why wouldn't they do that to everyone else if they had the power to conquer Earth?"

"We've read about your religious wars and conquests," Bow added.

"Those were hundreds of years ago," Pullman replied. "No one is calling for a crusade any more."

Catra scoffed. "I think some people in your country would disagree about that."

"Anyway, that's why we won't share our technology with a country we cannot trust to at least accept us as we are," Adora said. "But there's another reason for that. Those people who want us gone just because we love each other, because they think others could see us and realise that they have the same feelings, they don't know how much pain and misery they cause. Catra and I, we were orphans, raised in the Horde by a… manipulative woman."

Catra leaned into her love. Shadow Weaver had a lot to answer for.

Adora took a deep breath. "She left us ignorant of what love was - we didn't realise what we were feeling for each other. As a result, we hurt each other, very much. We almost killed each other - we almost doomed our world over this." She raised her chin. "We don't want anyone else going through this pain. And that is why we won't share our technology with any country where people can do this to each other."

"Legally, that is," Bow added.

"Yes." Adora stared at the camera. "Because you cannot trust someone like that - someone who can't be happy if you're happy with your love. We know this."

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The Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, September 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill closed his eyes and sighed. The Etherians didn't pull punches. "I thought they had some PR weenies advising them," he muttered.

"They do, yes," Carter replied.

"Then why did they just push every damn button of the conservatives?" Planned economy, monarchy, being worshipped as a god, gay marriage… He looked around - a number of the soldiers watching the interview looked angry.

"They haven't talked about magic yet," Daniel unhelpfully pointed out.

"I'm sure that'll happen as well," Jack told him. "But seriously? I thought they wanted to play nice with the conservatives!"

"I believe that they realised that the more extreme members of the conservatives are a hopeless cause and decided to appeal to the moderates," Teal'c commented.

Jack blinked and stared at his friend. Political commentary from Teal'c?

"I had ample time to watch television since our return, and I decided to educate myself on the domestic politics of the United States." Teal'c nodded.

Ah. Which was kind of worrying. But the interview went on.

"Let's address another subject that is controversial: Magic," Pullman said. "There have been several reports that you are planning to 'return magic' to Earth. Could you elaborate on this?"

"Well, it's simple," Adora said. "About a thousand years ago, the First Ones stole magic to power their superweapon to destroy Horde Prime - and they planned for a lot of collateral damage. They were stopped by my predecessor, Mara, but she couldn't return the stolen magic. Since we defeated Horde Prime, we've been working to return magic to the various planets." She smiled. "It's slow going, especially with the war, but we'll get there. And once we have won the war, we can use the Stargate Network to visit the affected planets more easily and much more quickly."

"Those planets which haven't been destroyed by Horde Prime," Glimmer added with a frown.

"So… you carry magic with you and then release it?" Pullman asked.

"Oh, no!" Entrapta shook her head. "That's not how it works. You can't store magic like that - well, you could, if you had the right crystal matrix, but it would be very hard to transport, and releasing it wouldn't return magic to the planet, not in the way that matters. Magic is constantly generated on life-bearing planets. Or it should. Anyway, the First Ones kind of shunted the magic generated off to collect it to power their weapon. It's a very complex and fascinating piece of magic engineering, actually. The possibilities if we could duplicate the basic mechanics…" She coughed. "Anyway, so, once you dismantle that shunt, the planet's magic is available again for the people on it."

"The natural order restored," Glimmer added.

"So, you claim that until a thousand years ago, magic was real on Earth? And then we lost access to it?" Pullman raised his eyebrows.

"Exactly," Entrapta said, nodding.

"We have no records of magic," Pullman retorted.

Bow frowned at that. "You have such records - we saw them. People turning into animals. Or controlling the weather or the sea. Flying through the sky."

"Healing the sick," Adora added. "Magic's all in your history."

"Those are myths," Pullman replied. "Are you claiming that those are historical records?"

"Well, a lot of historical records turn into myths over time when primary sources get lost or forgotten, linguistic drift happens…" Bow shrugged. "We experienced that on Etheria as well, and we have excellent archives in Bright Moon."

"Of course, a number of the recorded magic events and miracles might be the result of Goa'uld technology used to impress people," Entratpa said. "That wouldn't be magic, of course - the technology is completely different. But Earth magic is totally real - Adora can restore it."

"Many people think magic is evil," Pullman said cautiously.

"They're wrong," Adora replied bluntly. "Magic isn't good or evil, it's like… technology."

"You can use it for good or evil," Glimmer added. "Like everything else. And many people want magic back, according to the news. I heard there's going to be a formal petition from various people."

"Various indigenous people," Bow added. "Magic is an important part of their religion."

"I see. But many people are also concerned that 'restoring' magic would create inequality. Some people would be able to use magic, others wouldn't. That would create a huge power imbalance." Pullman tilted his head. "People fear that this would lead to a magical monarchy being imposed on Earth."

"They're wrong," Glimmer repeated Adora's words. "Or they're lying. You already have power imbalances and inequality. Some of your people - or countries - are vastly more powerful than the others. Magic wouldn't change anything about that - not fundamentally."

"It would just add another variable, so to speak," Bow said.

"A huge variable," Pullman insisted. "The ability to… to heal the sick is huge."

"Incorrect," Hordak spoke up. "On average, a sorceress is no real threat to a trained soldier. Few have the talent and discipline to even learn magic that can make a difference on the battlefield, and fewer still amount to a threat that can't be dealt with by a squad or two of soldiers with armour support. Even princesses,

who, thanks to their innate magic, don't have to study for years to learn how to cast spells, are rarely powerful enough to turn the tide on the battlefield by themselves."

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "My own magic talent is prehensile hair - very useful for lab work or housework, but I couldn't really do anything on the battlefield that a net launcher and some other weapons couldn't do as well. The elemental princesses are the exception since they are bonded to runestones, which Earth lacks." She smiled. "So, you don't have to fear that, once magic is restored, princesses are taking over. Not that we know if you'll even have princesses, mind you!"

"I see. But if magic is as weak as you say, why should it be restored in the first place if people oppose it?" Pullman asked. "They might be wrong, but their fear and loathing are real. Why should you ignore their wishes?"

"Because it's the same attitude we already covered," Catra said with a sneer: "Some people think magic is evil, so they don't want anyone else to use it."

"That's selfish and stupid," Glimmer added.

"Magic is a natural part of Earth - your birthright. It was stolen from you by the First Ones," Adora said. "Why should a part of you get to decide that no one can get it back? If you don't like magic, you can just not use it. But you shouldn't try to forbid others from using it! It's not any more dangerous than one of your guns."

"I see." Pullman nodded. "You've certainly made your position clear about that. Now, I already mentioned concerns that your arrival and magic might lead to the imposition of magical monarchies on Earth. You've explained your view of how with power comes responsibility - or duty. But what's your view of democracy?"

"Well… it's certainly an interesting concept," Glimmer said very diplomatically. "We don't have much experience with it. But if it works for you, then that's good for you."

"It's just that it doesn't seem to work for you as well as it should," Adora added.

"Yes!" Bow nodded several times. "Like when the majority wants something, but it doesn't matter because they're controlled by the minority."

"Or manipulated by your rulers," Catra said.

Jack closed his eyes once more. "Here we go again." The Etherians were going for a full sweep, it seemed.

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Alliances Part 1

Dulles International Airport, Washington DC, Earth, September 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and you can see that the interview resulted in more positive and more negative reactions amongst American conservatives. The polls we ran show that the number of moderate conservatives - those who held a slightly negative opinion of Etheria - shrunk as a result," Mr Brown explained, pointing at the big screen on Darla's bridge, where a diagram was displayed.

Adora frowned. That didn't sound like a good result. "We made more people hate us?"

"Yes. But you also made more people like you," Mr Brown said. "In short, you polarised the moderate conservatives. We're still analysing the exact reasons, but so far, it looks like your, ah, appeal to progressive family values was the central argument that convinced the more liberal of them, although many have other reasons as well, such as your willingness to defend Earth, while the other end of the spectrum saw their negative opinion confirmed by several of your statements. However, we're still not sure how many of the reasons given were merely excuses for reasons that made the difference but were less socially accepted."

"What? What do you mean?" Adora asked.

"Well…" Mr Brown glanced at Glimmer and Bow. "While few answered our respective questions directly, we have reasons to suspect - based upon other polls in the past - that the relationship between Queen Glimmer and Techmaster Bow also influenced them."

What? But Glimmer and Bow weren't… Oh! "That racism thing, right?" Adora asked.

"Yes. Although the overlap between people who show an extremely negative reaction to same-sex relationships and people who show negative reactions to interracial relationships is very high."

"Most racists," Julie cut in, "are also sexist and bigots. At least in the USA. But they don't want to be seen as racists, so they generally make up other reasons."

"Ah."

Catra snorted. "Idiots, all of them."

"Yes!" Bow agreed - with a rare expression of anger, Adora noted. And Glimmer…

"Well, fuck them!"

Yes, Glimmer was livid.

"So… we basically made the almost good ones better and the almost really bad ones worse?" Entrapta asked.

"Yes. As expected, actually. And the numbers are positive - together with the progressives, we're looking at a very solid majority of the Americans who have a positive opinion of you." Mr Brown nodded. "Helped along, of course, by the propaganda efforts of the government."

"Of course, that could and will change - opinions shift all the time," Julie said. "But you met expectations, more or less. And yes, the government's PR campaign is helping here, though they probably didn't appreciate your frank statements."

Well, that was their problem. Adora wouldn't lie to the people. And yet… "But we also increased the number of people who really hate us," she pointed out.

"That couldn't be helped," Julie told her. "You have very divisive opinions. And you didn't want to commit to a more extended

public relations campaign."

Adora frowned but didn't pout. It wasn't as if they had the time to 'interact with the public in casual ways' for weeks. And that sounded far too much like playing a role. And lying. 'Just be yourself' was no guarantee that people would like you. Entrapta and Catra were great, but you had to know them a bit to understand that.

"And some of your opinions are not well-received even amongst progressives and liberals," Mr Brown cautioned. "There are already attempts to paint you as communists because of the way your economy is set up. That may get some traction, though we might be able to counter that by stressing that we're talking about a war economy and showing the similarities to our own war economy during World War II."

"And the palace economy of Minoan culture," Bow added with a smile. "There are parallels, even if the social conditions are different."

Mr Brown and Julie looked as lost as Adora felt.

Bow sighed. "An ancient culture based on... Crete, I believe. Yes, ancient Crete. Daniel told me about it during the trip here."

"Ah." Mr Brown nodded. "I fear most Americans won't be able to place such a reference. A pity, I'm sure."

Catra snorted as Bow pouted.

Mr Brown went on: "Anyway, some of the more left-leaning segments also didn't like how you recruited and apparently pardoned your enemies after the war. It didn't play well with some of the civil rights activists either, but not enough to measurably affect their opinions. The religious aspect of your followers pretty much was a wash - the more religious ones who were affronted by what they saw as an attempt to replace God already were disapproving of you for your social stances - but your plan to

return magic did affect people who would have supported you otherwise."

"I thought we explained that their fears are baseless," Glimmer commented. "Even if they have the talent, they'll need years of training to do anything noticeable, much less anything impressive."

"Well, they don't believe you," Mr Brown said. "Interestingly, you have anti-colonialist activists split between those who think you are acting like colonialists, making decisions without concern about the opinions of the people affected, and those who laud your willingness to return magic to indigenous cultures despite the objections of former colonialist societies."

Not for the first time, Adora wondered what was wrong with Earth. "We won't return magic if no one wants it back," she said. "But we know people want it back."

"You don't have to tell me that," Mr Brown said. "I've seen the polls. Anyway, basically, we're talking about a solid majority in support of gay marriage now."

"Great!" Adora beamed.

"Of course, for actual changes in legislation, that doesn't mean much. What matters is whether or not you have a solid, even a supermajority, in the House of Representatives and the Senate," Julie said. "And the states."

Adora blinked. It was all for nothing?

"Well, that will take a while to shake out, and we can't poll the politicians, so we should focus on your next interview," Mr Brown said.

"Right." Adora sighed.

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Pentagon, Washington DC, Earth, September 16th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and those polls are clearly biased! Why would anyone change their opinion after seeing just how depraved and dangerous those aliens are? The government should stand up to their insane demands! We all - all the patriots, at least - have taken the pledge! One Nation under God, indivisible, with liberty and justice for all! And this offence against God is no justice at all!"

Samantha Carter pressed her lips together and stood up, walking towards the TV in the corner of the canteen. A warrant officer almost dropped his tray to get out of her way. She reached the remote control and quickly changed the channel to something less stupid.

"Hey!" A man at one of the closer tables stood. "What are you doing? Change it back!"

She eyed him. He was a major - he technically outranked her. But he was an Army staff officer, and she was Stargate Command's best scientist. "The television is supposed to show the news," she told him.

"This is the news!"

"Technically, this isn't news but entertainment, despite the name," Daniel spoke up in support of her from their table. He smiled at the glare from the major. "That's what they claim."

"But they show the news!"

"No," Sam told him. "They show some selected polarising 'interviews' in an attempt to gain better ratings. There is nothing informative about the rantings of extremists."

"Why are you calling them extremists?"

"Because they *are* extremists." She glared at him. This should have been obvious. "They refuse to acknowledge facts to push

their own narrative." And every scientist knew that that was a cardinal sin.

"They're just stating their opinion."

"And we don't need to listen to their opinion," she retorted. "Not in the canteen. What you do in the privacy of your home is your business, but this kind of propaganda has no place in the Armed Forces of the United States." She turned away before he could retort and stalked back to her table. Where, she saw with a sinking feeling, the Colonel had joined Daniel.

He grinned at her. "Wow, you read the man the riot act. And he outranks you! Way to go, Carter!"

She refused to blush. "I was merely enforcing regulations, Sir," she said as she sat down stiffly.

"Yeah, yeah, Carter." The Colonel snorted but quickly grew serious. "We're all sick of the stuff."

"Actually, the reactions of the various segments of the population are fascinating," Daniel retorted.

"You wouldn't say this if you had been at the meeting I just had to attend," the Colonel said.

"Oh?" Sam raised her eyebrows, prompting him as much as she would.

"Yes. Kinsey," he all but snarled. "He's got his hooks into the government."

"We, ah, already knew that," Daniel said with a frown."

"No, we knew he had influence - but he's now running an NID operation to shatter the right-wing movement in the United States. And the government has basically given him carte blanche."

"What? But… that's illegal!" Daniel protested.

"Yes." The Colonel's smile was devoid of any humour.

"Then we have to report this!"

"Report what? It was all between the lines." The Colonel scoffed. "Kinsey didn't say he was going to blackmail, frame and assassinate people whose political views were in the way of government aims. He was talking about 'persuading' and 'offering incentives', and 'making them see reason' and 'exposing those who preach water and drink wine'."

Ah. Sam nodded. "But the NID could still make mistakes, and their machinations could become exposed." She had a few ideas on how to arrange that.

Usually, the Colonel would say something like, 'machinations, Carter? Did you fall asleep on the dictionary yesterday?' But he merely shook his head. "Yes. And then?"

She pressed her lips together. She knew what he was thinking.

Daniel, though, frowned. "Then they'll get arrested, and the whole illegal operation exposed."

"And then?" The Colonel asked, staring at their friend.

"Their victims get exonerated, the government will have to… Oh." Daniel blinked.

"...drop any plans to pass gay marriage legislation as the right-wingers resurge with popular support as the victims of evil government manipulations," the Colonel finished for him. "And the United States can forget about an alliance with the Etherians because we'll be doubling down on the anti-gay legislation."

That wouldn't be the only thing such a comeback of the right-wing conservatives would bring, Sam knew. If they gained the presidency and control of Congress, they would also try to crack

down on women's rights. Funnel more money into the military, of course - but without the help of the Etherians, and most of Stargate Command working directly for the United Nations, much of that money would be wasted. "They'll also call us away from the Stargate," she said. They would want everyone with knowledge of the aliens working for the USA.

"But…" Daniel looked lost. "They wouldn't do that, would they?"

"Daniel!" the Colonel snapped. "They've been crying for exactly that ever since they heard that the aliens aren't heterosexual Aryan princesses."

Sam blinked. "'Heterosexual Aryan princesses', Sir?"

He frowned at her. "I was quoting the Secretary of Education."

Ah.

"So…" Daniel licked his lips. "Are we going to, ah, sit on this, then?"

The Colonel snorted once more. "That's the question, isn't it?"

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, September 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and the protests in Riad turned into riots as a mob assaulted several embassies of European countries…"

"...the state of emergency in Egypt has been prolonged indefinitely as the civil unrest continues, the armed forces and the police cracking down on any protests to avoid a repeat of the Goa'uld riots in…"

"...statement from the Vatican that the Pope is still deliberating and urges the faithful to remain calm and kind to those in need…"

"...has resigned after serving twenty years as Senator, citing that recent events make it impossible to serve both his personal principles and the needs of the country. His successor will be appointed by the governor of…"

"...arrested and charged with multiple counts of embezzlement. His church declined to comment on…"

"...hat der Bundestag die erste Lesung des geplanten Gesetzes abgeschlossen und weitere Änderungen vorgeschlagen. Der Bundeskanzler erklärte, er sei enttäuscht, dass das Parlament die Dringlichkeit der Gesetzesänderung offenbar nicht ganz realisiert habe, und…"

"...Prime Minister's refusal to comment on the apparent favoured treatment of the United States in comparison fueled speculation that his diplomatic efforts had encountered obstacles that passing the gay marriage act in Parliament wouldn't solve, yet…"

"...le Président de la République est arrivé à Genève, où il va rencontrer la reine Glimmer…"

"Can you stop switching channels all the time? I want to actually understand what they are saying!"

Catra snorted at Glimmer's familiar complaint and switched channels a few more times. "It's not my fault you're too slow, Sparkles."

"Slow?"

"Yeah!" Catra nodded. "I got everything I needed."

"Really."

"Yes." She smirked.

"And what did you get from switching through three dozen channels in a minute or so?" Glimmer crossed her arms and glared at her.

"That nothing much has changed. The people on Earth are still rioting because we aren't following their customs, and their rulers still try to flatter us at every opportunity." Catra grinned. "You really should reconsider not accepting gifts - I am sure Adora would have enjoyed that private island we were offered."

Glimmer clenched her teeth. "Those were bribes! The man expected Etherian weapons in exchange!"

"So?" Catra shrugged again. "Just hand him some spears and swords." The man hadn't specified which weapons, after all, he wanted.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Yeah, that's exactly what we need - a reputation for trickery and deception!"

"It would be an improvement over 'witchcraft', 'carnal sin', 'heathen debauchery', 'offending God' and…"

"I've seen the report!" Glimmer snapped. "And things are improving."

"In some countries," Catra pointed out. "We've been basically banned from entering an entire region."

"And other regions are complaining that we haven't visited them yet," Glimmer retorted.

"The people or the governments?" Catra grinned at her friend's scowl. "Anyway, we don't need them. We just need a few countries and their armies to start conquering planets."

"*Liberating* planets!" Glimmer glared at her again. "And the more allies we have, the more effective we'll be in the long run."

"Provided they don't betray us." Catra scoffed. Not everyone was as untrustworthy as Double Trouble, but a number of the people they had met here…

"That's why we are doing all those negotiations. Not that you're doing much," Glimmer complained.

"I'm analysing them and keeping Adora from being swayed by their sob stories," Catra retorted. "If you want me to actually negotiate, just say so!"

Glimmer scoffed in return. "And have you fleece the Earth countries out of their treasury?"

"Well… we can use it for the war?" She flashed her fangs. "Even with the support from the fleets, and with Perfuma doing her plant growth thing, it'll be costly."

Glimmer sighed and sat down in the seat next to her. "I know. We still haven't recovered from the Horde War. And the Earth people want to open free trade with us."

Catra frowned. "So? They are really desperate for our technology. We could make a killing!"

"Yes, until they have our technology, and then we get flooded with cheap Earth products." Glimmer shook her head. "Bow has read up on that. We need to be really careful with any trade agreement."

Catra would have to read up on that stuff as well, then. She knew how to wage war, but trade politics… In the Horde, you just requisitioned everything. Trade was for the black market in the barracks. "So… stick to the military?"

"That's the plan. But they have plans of their own."

"They're not stupid, despite all this." Catra pointed at the screen on the wall.

"I know. I just wish they'd stop being stupid where it matters." Glimmer sighed. "We've got a meeting with the French president in ten minutes. Where is Adora?"

"She is still reading up on French history with Bow." As if there'd be a test later on.

"Ah." Glimmer nodded.

"And how did your talk with the Australians go?" Catra asked.

"They wanted to know more about magic. I'm not sure they fully understood my explanations - or Entrapta's." Glimmer shrugged. "They don't get that Earth magic isn't the same as Etherian magic. They don't have runestones. They don't have Mystacore. They think once magic is back, people will spontaneously start flying and throwing lightning around." She scoffed. "It's frustrating."

"Better you than me." Catra grinned again.

"You're up for the strategy meeting with NATO as soon as we can get a time and date."

Catra hung her head. Great.

*****

Pentagon, Washington DC, Earth, September 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and speculation about who will succeed as senator is rampant, with the governor remaining tight-lipped about any prospects, but with the polls showing that a majority of the state's population support a more progressive stance, he is expected to…"

So, it had begun. Jack O'Neill pressed his lips together as he forced himself to turn away from the television and focus on his jello. He would bet all his desserts for the next ten years that the senator in question hadn't resigned out of his free will but had been forced to by Kinsey and the NID. The guy was claiming some noble principles and the good of the country, but Jack didn't believe any of it. It just didn't fit the man's policies.

So, it wasn't a great loss to see that politician go. It might actually be a good thing if he was replaced by someone not as selfish and greedy, but the man had been elected by a majority of his state's voters. Forcing him to step down through underhanded means was a blow against democracy and the rule of law. Against the constitution Jack had sworn to defend.

"So… what do we do?" Daniel asked. "About that, I mean." He gestured at the television as if there was any doubt about the topic of the conversation.

Out of habit, Jack glanced around. Still no one close enough to overhear them. "We don't actually have any proof," he said, trying not to wince at his own words. They sounded like… excuses.

"Without proof, there is no way to legally stop this," Carter pointed out.

"So we would be breaking the law if we did anything?" Daniel sounded weirdly hopeful and desperate at the same time. "And we don't have proof, so we don't really know…"

Jack hesitated for a moment, then shook his head. He didn't like excuses. "We do know. This…" He pointed at the screen, then blinked. They had already switched to covering the latest scandal involving a minister, a luxury yacht and church donations. "Well, that too. We know this is the work of the NID using illegal means to affect national policy. We don't have proof, yes, but this is no coincidence." This was Kinsey at work.

"Yes, but…" Daniel fell silent, then raised his chin. "We also 'know' what will happen if this gets exposed."

"That's a good guess," Jack replied. Then he raised his hands, "Yes, I also think if the NID gets thwarted, we'll see the right-wing nutters take over." It would be just like Watergate. The public wouldn't tolerate such blatantly illegal acts by the government.

"'Thwarted', Jack?" Daniel blinked.

Jack stared at him. “Not the point, Daniel.”

“Uh, right. Anyway - so… what do we do? Whatever we do would be breaking the law, sort of.”

“It’s not against the law to keep speculation to yourself,” Carter, prim and proper as usual, said. “Without any proof or even clues except for the timing, we aren’t required to take action.”

“Yes,” Daniel agreed. “Otherwise, we would have witch hunts all the time. I don’t mean literal witch hunts.”

Those were good arguments. Sound, logical, perfectly fine. But Jack knew that they were excuses, nothing more. Under different circumstances, he would be doing all he could to stop the NID. And Carter and Daniel would be with him all the way. Doing the right thing, no matter the cost.

But what if the cost was America? There was some Latin saying about justice and the world ending that Jack did not quite remember from West Point. Something about enforcing justice even if it doomed the world. Did he want that?

He snorted, startling Carter and Daniel. If he did, he would have quit the Air Force long ago. Some of the things he had done during the Cold War… His friends were still staring at him. He sighed. “We don’t have any proof. And doing anything illegal to gather proof…” Carter blushed a little, he noticed. “...would have us act like the NID.” Not quite, but close enough. At least for his conscience.

“You could argue that the only reason this is happening is because the American system is flawed, so a minority has too much influence, controlling the majority,” Daniel said. “So, those suffering from the NID breaking the law were already violating the spirit of the law.”

Jack stared at him. “Let’s not sound too smug or noble, OK?”

Daniel blushed. “OK. So… we don’t do anything. Illegal, I mean.”

"Yes." Jack nodded. As did Carter.

He turned to look at the television again. They were showing a report from some country in Africa - he had missed the start. Something about witch hunts. The reporter sounded concerned in that professional way some managed.

"...and the reports of people lynched after being accused of being 'witches' keep increasing. The government has announced that in light of the Etherian threat to restore magic, they will outlaw witchcraft. In response, a rebel faction has called upon the population to 'embrace the ancient magic of our people'. Experts disagree about…"

And there were the literal witch hunts. Jack scowled. If they or the NID bungled this, this could become the future of America. He'd do a lot more to avoid this than turn a blind eye to rumours.

No matter how bad it made him feel.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, September 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora was prepared. She had read up on the history of France - and there had been a lot of revolutions and quasi-revolutions; they were up to their fifth republic! - and on the current politics of the country and on the Président himself. She was prepared.

But she was still nervous when she walked towards the meeting room. She had only briefly met the man before, she didn't know any French people she could have trusted to tell her more about him, and the news was pretty divided about him.

Catra stretched next to her, then leaned over. "Relax. He wants something from us, not the other way around."

"We want allies on Earth," Adora whispered back. Allies they could trust. If only SG-1 were princesses - well, princes and one

princess - in charge of the USA! “And we need allies.”

“Not as much as they need us,” Glimmer cut in from Adora’s other side. “If everything fails, we don’t need to share technology - Earth troops can fight the Goa’uld on the ground just fine, as SG-1 has proven.”

“Yeah,” Catra agreed. “Though in the long run, we might be pressed for resources.”

Adora knew that. Second and Third Fleet had their logistical tails and could get resupplied. Bots could be used. Entrapta and Hordak also were positive that they could rebuild Horde Prime’s cloning facilities. Well, replace them - the originals were currently part of the space plant above Etheria. But that should be the clones’ decision, not anyone else’s. And it certainly shouldn’t be done because they needed more soldiers.

Of course, if they managed to get an alliance, the point would be moot.

They reached the meeting room and entered.

The Président was tall, was Adora’s first thought. Not as tall as She-Ra, but… maybe half a head shorter? Which meant he was far taller than her friends and herself.

“Queen Glimmer! Princess She-Ra!” The Président beamed at them, shaking their hands - she had half-expected him to kiss their hands, based on some reports about the French. But he had a firm handshake.

“Monsieur le Président,” Glimmer nodded at him.

“Hello!” Adora added.

“Techmaster Bow. Catra.” More smiles all around, even if Catra’s was a little toothy.

Then they met his staff. General Dubois. And the Minister des Armées. And what Catra called flunkies or minions.

"I am so happy to meet you again," the man told her as they took their seats at the table - decorated with the French flags and… the Princess Alliance Crest. That was a nice touch!

Adora smiled at the Président. "Yes." They had met briefly before, when they had met the United Nations. But this was their first personal meeting.

"It's an honour," Glimmer replied.

"The honour is all mine." Another smile. "I hope to invite you to France one day - you must see Paris, one of the most beautiful cities in the world. The City of Love, she is known as."

Adora didn't have to glance to the side to see Catra perk up.

"That would be lovely," Glimmer said. "Should we form an Alliance, then signing the agreement would be a great occasion to visit."

Adora nodded. Perhaps they should have visited for this meeting, but… Geneva was close to France, and they had so many meetings with the Security Council anyway. Besides, this was mostly a preliminary meeting, according to the schedule.

"France would be honoured."

"As would we," Glimmer told him. "But let's get down to business. Let's talk about an alliance."

*****

"...and we will pass legislation that will grant everyone, no matter their sexual orientation, the same rights to marriage and everything that entails, including adoption." The Président nodded. "We expect the laws to be passed soon."

Adora nodded. She could have done without the list of France's achievements with regards to human rights - she had read up on the country - but it would have been rude to mention that.

"Now, I'd be the first to admit that we're not perfect. France has done much to be ashamed of in the past. Sometimes out of ignorance, sometimes for worse motivations," he went on. "But we strive to be better than we were."

Adora nodded again. She had read up on that as well. "As everyone should."

"No one's perfect," Glimmer added. "We understand that."

"So we've heard." The Président didn't look at Catra, Adora noted. But it was clear what he meant.

And Catra knew it - Adora saw that she was pretty tense. She reached over and patted her knee. Catra had changed. She wasn't the Catra who had led the Horde any more. Well, she was, in some ways, but not the ones that counted most.

"As long as you don't go back, this will be fine," Glimmer said. "Of course, laws also need to be enforced to matter."

"France is a country of law and order. We will enforce those laws." He smiled again. "You have my word. Although I don't expect many problems - it's not as if we are limiting people's rights; we're expanding them. That rarely causes any problems with people."

"Except for the bigots," Catra said. "They hate that."

"We have a handle on them," the Président told her. "France is a secular, laicist state with a strict separation of religion and state. The religious extremists do not hold any power here."

That was aimed at the USA, Adora was certain.

But Glimmer didn't comment. "Now, with that dealt with, let's talk about the military."

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Capitol, Washington DC, Earth, September 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"But can't we outproduce them? They said their planet has a population of fifty million - we have six times that number!"

Samantha Carter had to refrain from correcting the senator that the United States' population was five and a half times Etheria's. That wouldn't only further alienate the man and his conservative cohorts. So she gently shook her head and repeated what she had been telling her superiors and various members of the government since they had returned from Etheria: "If we had the same technology and resources, we could. But we don't. We don't have enough people who understand alien technology."

"Can't we teach more people?" another conservative senator asked. His accent sounded as if he had stepped out of 'Gone with the Wind'.

The people who understood alien technology enough were not good teachers. Sam included herself in that category, seeing as she really wanted to curse at her audience. She had gone over that before! It was in her reports!

"We would have to teach all scientists and all engineers. And then every worker. And we would still lag behind the Etherians' technology. They, on the other hand, have a fleet full of people who know to use, maintain and create alien technology. They can teach that to others much more easily than we can. And on Etheria, they have a society used to both magic and technology." Sam shook her head. And there was also the threat of brain drain - those who came to study and work in the USA because it was the most advanced nation would look elsewhere if the USA lost that position.

"A society that's still using swords and bows and arrows," the first senator said.

“Magic swords and arrows. They defeated an army that had hovertanks with laser cannons,” Sam shot back. She was fudging the truth a little here, but only a little. “They aren’t primitive. They have different aesthetics, that’s all. People in the USA hunt with bow and arrow, yet we don’t think the USA is stuck in the medieval age, do we?” Why couldn’t they see that? The rest of the conservative senators did!

“My cousin swears by his composite bow,” a third senator - an overweight older man from the South - said with a smile. “I swear by my Remington, of course.”

“That’s irrelevant. The question we’re here to answer is: Can we defy those aliens who attempt to force their ideology on us and chart our own course as a proud nation, or do we have to bend our necks and accept their demands so we will not be relegated to a third-world country?” the first senator snapped.

“They don’t make demands, Senator,” Sam corrected him. “They have requirements to be met for anyone who wants access to their technology.”

“Semantics!” the senator who had asked after teachers said. “If we want their technology, we have to bend to their whims. That’s what it boils down to.”

“Well, they’re just doing what we did to our backyard,” another said with a chuckle.

Sam cleared her throat, then had to wait a few moments before the assembled senators turned their attention back on her. Why exactly had the President sent her to talk to those people? She knew their type; they didn’t like listening to women as a rule, and if the woman was pretty and young… She managed not to clench her teeth. Well, the Colonel would have lost his patience long ago and would have antagonised everyone with his flippant remarks, and Daniel… would have lectured them in his earnest but accidentally offensive way.

Still, as grating as this was, she had faced worse sexists. "As I said, senators, if the United States is forced to tackle upgrading our technology without any help from the Etherians, we will lag behind. We simply aren't on a sufficient level, educationally, scientifically and with regards to infrastructure, to match whatever country they support."

"But ultimately, we'll catch up, right?" the first senator asked again. "We might have a slower start, but we're the United States - we will persevere. With God's help, we'll show them!"

"By the time we catch up to where they are now, they will have progressed even further. And we would have to spend a lot of resources just to catch up - money we could spend on more advanced programs." Not that education didn't need a huge investment, but this wasn't the crowd to address that even - or especially - since they were the exact crowd who had caused the damage to the United States' schools and colleges.

"We would certainly lose our role as leader of the free world," another Senator who had stayed silent so far spoke up. "And we wouldn't have the strongest military in the world any more. Not when the French and the British are rolling over and showing their bellies to the aliens just so they can get spaceships."

Of course, that made an impression on the politicians in the room. Sam refrained from scoffing - whether or not the USA had the strongest military in the world didn't matter, not when six ships in orbit could easily defeat the entire world's militaries.

"So, we either grant the dykes the right to marry each other and raise children, or we lose everything we have achieved in the last two hundred years."

No one batted an eye at the man's slur, Sam noted. But most nodded in reluctant agreement.

"At least a chunk of my state is in favour of this," one senator said. "According to the polls at least."

“Lucky you. My constituents will murder me for this,” another said.

“Aren’t they busy murdering your church right now?”

“It wasn’t my church! I have attended a few services there, but I hardly knew the minister! And I certainly wasn’t aware of his… inclinations!”

Ah! So that scandal was happening in his state. Sam kept a polite expression on her face as the senators complained about having to go along with the government’s proposals.

She just wished she could already leave. More such meetings and she might become as bad as the Colonel about politicians.

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, September 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“...and we can send la Légion d’Étrangère out at once - it’s one of the best units in the world and ready to deploy,” the Minister des Armées said. “Though they would need support from other forces - they don’t have integral air support.”

Catra nodded. “Unlike the US Marine Corps.” She had read up on Earth's military history.

The French general frowned. “Of course, how valid air support is on foreign planets remains to be seen. And going up against space ships?” He shrugged. “I assume you have sufficient space forces to take over this, and we can handle everything on the ground, provided our intel about the enemy forces is correct.”

“It should be,” Adora said. “Teal’c was a highly placed officer, and he didn’t know about any armour units in the ranks of the Jaffa.”

“Or artillery.” Which was a weird deficiency. How could you wage war without armour and artillery? Well, if you had princesses to pick up the slack, you could, Catra amended. “They are said to

rely on their bombers for such support. But the core of their ground forces is composed of infantry. And Earth-made weapons are very competitive in that area." She had examined the zats and staff weapons herself. And the American rifles.

The French general nodded. "That is a small consolation. To find ourselves completely outclassed, and many of our best weapons rendered obsolete, was a heavy blow."

"Of course, it helped that every army on Earth was rendered obsolete at the same time," the French Président added with a chuckle. "Our pride might have suffered some blows, but others who used to look down on us suffered relatively worse."

Which meant the US Army, Catra knew. There was, well, she wouldn't call it a feud, but certainly some bad blood there. And the French were supposed to be allies of the Americans. Then again, the USA hadn't exactly been honest with the rest of the world - and also more than a little arrogant, or so it seemed.

"But a few thousand soldiers are not enough to tackle an Empire that spans the galaxy. We'll have to mobilise more, and that will take some time. As will converting our existing weapon designs to incorporate advanced technology," the minister went on.

"Well, the Goa'uld Empire is, as far as we know, fractured. After the death of Ra, his underlings split and started fighting each other. Or at least competing with each other," Glimmer added. "And this is a weakness of theirs."

"Yes," Catra agreed. "If we can keep them divided, we can defeat them piecemeal." What the Horde had almost done to the Alliance. "We have the edge in technology, and we can concentrate our forces as long as we have the initiative. If we use a few flotillas to strike various planets far apart, we can force them to spread out their ships to cover their realms. Of course, that will become harder and harder as we take more planets. So, it's essential that we develop ground-based weapons to protect planets and more ships."

“France will do what she can to help there,” the Président said. “Our industry is ready for this challenge. Even the unions agree,” he added, which prompted some chuckling from the others with him.

“But we won’t be able to win this war on the defensive,” Catra went on. “We need to take out their leaders and either conquer or destroy their core industries to cripple their ability to wage war. Most of the planets they control aren’t important from a strategic sense - they don’t have any infrastructure other than some mines, and they only have as many troops and gear their that they can supply through the Stargate.” Which, Catra didn’t need Teal’c to tell her that, was great for travelling, but not so great if you had to supply an army through it - much less several armies and bases.

“And we want to avoid pushing them into fighting to the bitter end,” Adora added.

Catra kept her mouth closed. It was a sound decision - an enemy who had nothing to lose would fight harder than someone who could surrender - but she didn’t think many, if any, of the Goa’uld could be trusted to stick to an agreement if they were even willing to make one in the first place. It would have to entail giving u their slaves, after all.

“As long as we can keep Earth and Etheria safe,” the Président said.

“That’s the main objective, of course,” Glimmer agreed. “Strategically.”

“But back to the alliance,” the Président said. “We’ve covered the laws we’ll change. Is there anything else left to discuss that needs to be altered?”

“As long as you make an honest effort to enforce the new laws and don’t start conquering other countries, I don’t think so,” Glimmer said.

Adora nodded.

“Then we need to discuss how the command structure will work,” Catra said. “Who’s in charge of which operations, how discipline is being handled.”

“Trade agreements, training, how to keep restricted knowledge safe from spies,” Glimmer added.

“With regards to trade, that would have to involve the European Union,” the Président replied.

“Well, we won’t really see much trade for the foreseeable future, what with the distance between Etheria and Earth,” Glimmer said.

And the issues about economic imbalances, Catra added to herself. France had more people than Etheria as a whole. And they were also meeting with the British and Germans. At least all of them were in the same Union which should simplify trade agreements.

Still, she preferred to talk tactics and strategy rather than trade, so she leaned back while Glimmer and Bow started talking about economic details. It looked like they would have their first ally on Earth soon enough.

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Alliances Part 2

Capitol, Washington DC, Earth, September 17th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill didn't like politicians. No matter their party affiliation, the lot of them were generally more concerned with pandering to their backers - and looking good to their constituents - than doing what was good for the country. At least Hammond was aware of that and had sent Carter to talk to the idiots who still hadn't gotten the message that the times of playing the usual games were over. Or at least suspended for the duration of the current crisis.

But that meant that he was stuck with watching how the cabinet tried to deal with the fact that the French had stolen a march on the United States.

"Look, they haven't signed an alliance yet. That is contingent on legalising gay marriage, and the French haven't done that yet," the Secretary of Agriculture said.

Why the man was voicing his opinion on this, Jack didn't quite understand. Perhaps he had dealt with the French over cheese and champagne exports and thought that had made him an expert?

"They'll pass those laws in a heartbeat. With the alliance all but signed, they won't hesitate," the Secretary of State replied. "The French Président doesn't have to deal with a bunch of religious nutcases who think God is American and they are the chosen people. When did the conservatives actually start believing in their own propaganda?"

The man must be either exhausted or incredibly annoyed, in Jack's opinion - he usually was far more restrained.

"Most don't believe that," the President replied. "But they have grown used to the status quo. And they have been cultivating the religious right for years. They fear that they are riding a tiger and can't get off without getting mauled."

And that was why Jack didn't like politicians. If you were a patriot, you did what was best for your country, no matter the cost for yourself. Soldiers were ready to lay down their lives for America, and those hypocrites in Congress were baulking at the thought of losing their seats?

"A tiger? More like a lemming," the Secretary of Education commented with a snort. "A lemming grown fat on money from bribes and running heedlessly towards the edge of the cliff."

"Now, to be fair, no one could have predicted that we'd make contact with helpful aliens who care about gay rights," the Secretary of Agriculture retorted.

"That doesn't matter. Have you seen what they were doing to America's education, all in the name of their ideology? Intelligent design! Chastity as sexual education! Cutbacks on public education wherever they could! They were ruining America long before we opened that gate!"

Jack refrained from smiling at the rant as the President spoke up. "Now, now - let's not dwell on the past. We have the future to deal with. And we have most of the conservatives in Congress on board. Or we'll have them, once the holdouts realise that they can't do any horse-trading like usual. Not with their own backers breathing down their necks."

"And the true believers?" the Secretary of the Interior asked.

"I think Captain Carter's briefing today helped impress upon them that their views of the situation were not entirely correct," the Chief of Staff replied.

"Must be tough to realise that your god abandoned you." The Secretary of Education snorted again.

The President frowned at her. “Anyway, if we just wanted to pass a federal law, we could do that easily. But as I was told by our experts, that won’t be enough for the Etherians.” He glanced at Jack, who straightened in response. Daniel had been the one who had explained to the Etherians how the United States worked, including the role of the Supreme Court, but Jack was the leader of SG-1, and so it was his responsibility.

“Why can the French do it, and we need to amend our constitution?” The Secretary of Agriculture pouted.

“Because they have a different system,” the Secretary of Education told him. “They don’t have a Supreme Court in charge who could change its rulings whenever they chose to.”

“The Supreme Court can’t just change its rulings.”

“Of course they can. They did it before with the death penalty, remember?” The woman scoffed. “And the magical princesses from the space kingdom are all too aware how that works when someone is elected for life without any checks and balances.”

“You can’t compare the Supreme Court to an absolute monarch!”

“I just did.”

“Folks!” the President spoke up again. “There’s no point to bicker about the hand we’ve been dealt. We have to play it. So… assume the French seal the deal in a few days; how long until they start building spaceships?”

Damn. The President was looking at Jack again. And this was a question for Carter, not for him. “They will have to spend months just learning the new technology,” Jack repeated what Carter had told him. “And unless they want to copy a Horde frigate, they will have to design a ship as well.”

“They’ll want their own designs. The French always do,” the Secretary of Agriculture claimed.

Jack wasn't so sure. The French had cooperated with other countries in the aerospace industry before. Airbus was the most famous example.

"Well, even if the French get a headstart, it won't matter much as long as we can get an alliance in a few weeks to a few months," the Secretary of State said.

"As long as the Etherians have enough teachers to cover all our needs," the Secretary of Education pointed out. "I don't think they'll stop their first teaching programs just to start with us. They might expect us to work together with everyone else."

Jack wasn't the only one who winced. The United States had trouble getting the Air Force and the Navy to cooperate - all the fault of the Navy pukes who didn't want to admit that space was covered by the Air Force - but to work so closely with the Europeans? The French didn't like America, and the Brits probably hadn't forgotten the whole Skybolt mess. Or the Suez Crisis. Or the Tizard Mission.

Great.

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, September 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...the secretary general of NATO confirmed today that the member states have collectively decided that the attack by the Goa'uld constitutes sufficient cause to trigger Article 5. Following this, the individual member states are expected to officially declare war, although to preserve operational security, the Goa'uld Empire will not be formally notified of this, which has several experts on International law express their doubts about the legality of the current and future hostilities…"

"...the police had to intervene to protect anti-war protestors from counter-protestors in Washington DC…"

"...several US embassies were the target of protests claiming that the United States were the aggressor in the conflict with the Goa'uld Empire…"

"...and many are wondering, with NATO invoking Article 5 and France about to sign an Alliance with the Etherians, whether or not a formal alliance with the Etherians is still necessary. We don't know the details of the alliance yet, but if France is fighting as part of NATO and allied to the Etherians, that would forge close ties between the Alliance and NATO, and that…"

"...and has no one looked at the money? How many defence contractors are pressuring their bought and paid for members of Congress to vote in favour of this travesty of justice just so they can profit from the war? Are we really willing to sell our souls for profit? I say: NO! This is a conspiracy to corrupt the heart of America so…"

"That weird conservative channel still hasn't changed," Adora commented as she switched the television in the waiting room off. They were still focusing on the extremists.

"Well, they claim that they are merely showing both sides of the issue equally," Bow told her, looking up from his tablet.

Catra snorted. "Yeah, right."

Adora looked over. Her lover was… you couldn't call it sitting; Catra was sprawled in one of the seats in the waiting room, back arched over the armrest as she looked upside down at the others in the room. "At least they are showing the positive reactions as well, now," Adora said.

"How nice." Catra, obviously, didn't think this was a sign of progress.

"Let's focus on today's meeting," Glimmer said. "The British delegation is supposed to arrive in twenty minutes - unless their flight gets delayed."

“Maybe we should have landed in London,” Adora said. “This is close to France but not to England.”

“The French Président still had to fly in,” Glimmer retorted. “And it would be a snub to France if we went to London for the meeting with the British Prime Minister. And Geneva is one of the seats of the United Nations.”

“You just like the sweets here,” Catra commented.

Glimmer stuck out her tongue at Catra. She was in a good mood. Everyone was after they had finalised the agreement with the French. Now, if things with the British went well as well, and then with the Germans, they would be ready to start liberating planets. Too bad the United States were still dragging their feet - Jack and the others wouldn’t be able to help them until their country adjusted. “Well, let’s hope things go well today.”

“They should,” Glimmer said. “I just wish the people from Earth wouldn’t complicate everything so much.” She scoffed. “They have the United Nations taking control of the Stargate. And their NATO is now officially at war with the Goa’uld. And we’re forming an alliance separate from NATO. How can you wage war like that?”

“Well, if anyone can, you should know how, Commander,” Catra told her. “It sounds like the old Princess Alliance.”

“We didn’t have three partially overlapping alliances,” Glimmer retorted. “Planning who gets to use the Stargate will be a nightmare. Not just logistically, but who wants to bet that some nations will attempt to leverage control over the gate into influence over us?”

“I’m not going to take a sucker’s bet,” Catra declared promptly. “That’s Adora’s thing.”

“It’s not!” Adora protested. Just because she had made a few unfortunate bets as a cadet… She pouted at the grinning Catra.

"Let's get serious," Glimmer said. "We don't want the British to think we're not serious."

Adora spoke up before Catra could make a joke about Glimmer's wording. "Isn't it a snub, talking to the prime minister of a queen instead of the queen herself?" She might be a figurehead, but she was the head of state.

"It's not," Catra replied. "The Prime Minister is the actual ruler of the country."

Which was either England, the United Kingdom or Great Britain depending on what you read. A very weird country.

"Anyway, since the head of state is the queen," Glimmer said, "we can expect to meet her when we sign the alliance."

"If we sign an alliance," Catra said. "They didn't get the name 'perfidious Albion' for nothing, I bet."

"That was actually enemy propaganda," Bow countered.

"Like calling the Horde the 'Evil Horde'?" Catra grinned.

"That was just telling the truth!" Glimmer retorted.

"Guys, please!" Bow said. "Let's focus on the meeting."

Catra snorted. "It'll go like the one with the French did. We have something they want very badly, and they are willing to do what is needed to get a deal."

Adora frowned, but she couldn't really counter that argument.

*****

Pentagon, United States of America, Earth, September 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...so, the others are busy meeting the British, but that's politics, so they don't need us for that - Bow knows about our technology,

Glimmer is a trained sorceress in case they have questions about magic, and Catra and Adora know everything about our logistics, even though Catra acts as if she wasn't interested, and the French didn't have any questions that would have needed us - so we thought we could take the shuttle and visit you to do some science, but then they told us at the mountain that you were here, so we flew here to meet you, in case you had some free time to discuss this adaption of the anti-gravity generator you mentioned! I hope we aren't disturbing you when you're busy with something important!"

Samantha Carter liked Entrapta. She really did. But sometimes, the princess was a little too impulsive and enthusiastic. And Sam didn't like Hordak.

Then again, Entrapta's arrival had gotten Sam out of another meeting with recalcitrant conservative members of the House of Representatives who just couldn't be bothered to face reality. And she was very sick of having to listen to Bible quotes. So Sam smiled a the beaming princess and nodded at Hordak. "No, just another meeting."

"Ah." Entrapta nodded. "Good! As Catra and Glimmer say - and if they agree on something, you know it's true: If you have time for a meeting, you don't have anything important to do. Unless it's a diplomatic meeting, I think."

Sam suppressed a chuckle; they weren't alone at the landing pad at the Pentagon, and with the current struggle between the Navy and the Air Force over the Space Force, she didn't want to hand the Navy any ammunition. "Well, I'm available to look at your modifications to the generator."

"Great! I've changed the power modulation. And Hordak had a very interesting idea about the main regulator." Entrapta opened the shuttle's back to show her the generator stashed there.

"An obvious modification that any technician should have realised long ago," Hordak commented.

Sam suppressed her annoyed reaction at the implied insult. “The Goa’uld aren’t much for encouraging creativity amongst their slaves.”

“How very short-sighted of them. Although having been the target of a coup myself, I can understand that they might have thought drastic measures were necessary.”

“I don’t think Catra was trying to replace you when she sent me to Beast Island,” Entrapta said.

“She was working up to it. I merely preempted her attack.”

Sam tried to focus on the generator. She was already aware that Hordak, Entrapta and Catra shared a quite convoluted past. She didn’t really want to hear the details. Well, she did, but whatever she heard, she was supposed to report to her superiors. And that felt like a breach of trust.

So she cleared her throat. “I see you doubled the crystals here.”

“Yes. Added redundancy.” Entrapta nodded. “You can blow half the relays and still have full power! But it will need a case that will vent the power of the explosion. And that won’t offer the same protection as an armoured case.”

“Any external force that penetrates the hull and reaches the generator will likely wreck the vehicle anyway,” Hordak retorted. “Unless it’s a capital vessel, in which case losing a minor backup generator won’t affect its combat performance.”

“What about a cellular array?” Sam asked. “Earth tanks use a system to offer both armour protection and a way to vent an internal explosion away from the crew compartment.”

“Oh, yes!” Entrapta beamed. “That would work. It would even work for bots - it would keep their decision matrixes intact so they can continue learning after repairs.”

“That should enhance their long-term combat performance, yes,” Hordak agreed.

“So, how does that work? Oh, blast panels, maybe? Mounted so they resist force from one direction but can easily be pushed away into the other direction?”

Entrapta was a genius, Sam reminded herself. She nodded with a smile. “Yes - it’s quite obvious, isn’t it?”

Hordak frowned. “Only if you are used to weapons that use explosives as propellant. Energy-based weapons make such construction pointless.”

Sam knew a face-saving argument when she heard it and grinned. “You also need internal armour, though. And that will make it heavier.”

“Yes. Unless we could… Hm… if we calculate the maximum power a blown crystal array could develop, we would know the minimal amount of armour we need…” Entrapta scrunched her nose while she started tapping buttons on her multi-purpose-device. “That means… Hm… It is related to the amount of power transmitted to the generator, so whatever metals the power lines or blows up the regulator is the upper limit of what could reach the relay crystals, so…”

She was interrupted by a beeping noise.

Hordak frowned. “Someone’s trying to enter the shuttle.”

“Oh?”

Sam tensed. They were on a landing pad at the Pentagon. Who would be willing to disturb them? If it was the NID… No. They wouldn’t want to risk the Etherians’ anger. Kinsey had clearly understood that. “It might be important,” she said.

“Let’s check!” Entrapta was already on the way to the door controls.

Outside, two men in dress shirts and slacks, but without jackets or ties, waited. Both carried laptop cases - and both had multiple pens in their shirt pockets.

Sam could be mistaken, but this style? She was familiar with it.

"Dr Carter? Princess Entrapta? Mr Hordak? We're sorry to disturb you, but when we heard that you had a shuttle here, we couldn't resist. I'm Mark Bower; this is Gerald Cline. We're from NASA, and we'd like to talk to you!"

Sam knew it. And since no one had stopped them from bothering the alien shuttle, the brass approved of whatever they were here for.

Well, Sam was pretty sure she also knew what this was about.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, September 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and in addition to crafting the Marriage Rights Act, we've also adjusted the Human Rights Act. As soon as those receive Royal Assent, same-sex marriage, with all the duties and rights that marriage grants, will be legal in the United Kingdom. All people, regardless of their gender or sexual orientation, will have equal rights with regards to selecting their partner."

The British Prime Minister had been stressing the kingdom part of the United Kingdom Catra had noticed. And the role of the Queen of England. A rather transparent attempt to appeal to the princesses, in her opinion. And like the French, he hadn't mentioned that they had executed one of their kings after a revolution. Not that it mattered - that had happened centuries ago.

"Thank you!" Adora beamed. Catra was tempted to kick her under the table to remind her lover that the Earth politicians were trying to butter them up. Then again, that was Adora for you: always

willing to see the best in people. Even when they did their worst to her and her friends, like… She suppressed the urge to shake her head. That was the past; Catra couldn't change it. She could only do better in the future. Like here.

"It's very good to hear that," Glimmer said. "I assume your queen won't hold up the process for ceremonial reasons?"

And now Catra had to hide her grin. Glimmer smiled as politely as before, but the Prime Minister's slight flinch meant the small barb had found its mark. The British might have a queen, but she wasn't their actual ruler.

"I don't foresee any delays on that front," the man replied.

"Good!" Adora glanced at Glimmer for a change, not at Catra, before beaming at the delegation from the United Kingdom. "So, provided the act goes through, let's talk about military and technology!"

*****

"...and so the Royal Navy would expand to cover space as well. While we work on building our own space vessels, we would like to have our sailors gather experience in space combat on your ships," the British admiral finished.

Now that was a good idea, in Catra's opinion. That would certainly speed up the time until Earth had space assets worth a damn. She knew best how useless most cadets were before they got some experience in the field. "That sounds reasonable," she said.

"Of course, we would also like to purchase spaceships from you once our sailors are ready to crew them," the man went on. "It's very likely that we'll pattern our own production after your ships, after all, so this would make a lot of sense."

That might be going a little too fast, though. Catra didn't trust the British - or any Earth country - yet with their own spaceships.

“That is certainly a good way to train up your forces, but it will take quite some time until your people are proficient with handling and especially maintaining Horde frigates,” Adora said.

Time enough to see if they were trustworthy.

“We’re aware of that from our own history. But the sooner we start, the sooner we are ready.”

“There’s also the fact that the way the Horde frigates are run might not suit your navy,” Catra pointed out. “Horde Prime had his clones made to perform exactly as he wanted, and that’s how they still work in many areas.”

“Not big on lower ranks showing any initiative, was he?” the British general asked.

“Not at all,” Catra said, frowning. Anyone who stuck out got… brainwashed. Like Hordak. Or herself.

“Then our crews might be an advantage for you as well - we’ve got a long naval tradition that favours showing initiative,” the admiral said. “Of course, sailing the blue sea isn’t quite comparable to flying in space, but the basic principles of running a ship tend to remain the same - at least that was the case for us while we went from sailing ships to ironclads to dreadnoughts and to aircraft carriers.”

Catra tried not to sneer. She didn’t like water. And she didn’t remember her time with Horde ships fondly. Well, she had mixed feelings about conquering Salineas, but that wasn’t something she liked to dwell on either.

“Well, basically, yes,” Adora said with a smile. “At least that was our experience - we fought on sailing ships and in space.”

The British soldiers looked surprised at that. “You did?”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “Of course, it wasn’t a warship, and it floated above the water until it sank, but, yes, it was propelled by

sails and magic."

"The Horde had actual warships," Catra cut in. "Not sailing ships. But yes, there are quite a lot of similarities between those ships and Horde frigates."

"But copying Horde ships might be harder than adapting a few crucial systems to your own technology," Bow pointed out.

"We're aware of that. But we think the priority is now to get ships into space. And working designs tend to have fewer issues to work out than new designs," the admiral said.

"Hopefully fewer delays," the Prime Minister added. "We don't have decades to get the perfect ship. Good enough will have to do."

"Perfection is the enemy of good enough, yes," Bow said.

Catra had a comment about this, Adora and Shadow Weaver, but this wasn't the time or place for it. "So, let's talk about numbers," she said instead.

*****

Pentagon, United States of America, Earth, September 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...so, you see, if we had just one of your ships available for transporting supplies, we could settle Mars and start terraforming it! Unless, of course, our calculations of their minimum cargo capacity are wrong."

Jack O'Neill frowned as he approached the shuttle parked on one of the Pentagon's landing pads. Who was talking inside? As far as he knew, it was just Carter, Entrapta and Hordak in there. Perhaps he should have asked one of the guards outside, but that would have made him look as if he didn't know everything that was going on with the aliens.

Well, he trusted Carter. Absolutely. Even with that damn Russian. But he didn't trust the aliens. Entrapta was too naive and trusting, and Hordak was a former warlord whose 'change of heart' might not be as thorough as some, namely Entrapta, thought. Jack had dealt with warlords in his past.

So he stepped onto the ramp and called out: "Permission to come aboard?" And then had to suppress a wince. That was something a navy puke would say - and space was Air Force turf.

"Jack?" Entrapta replied. "Come in! It's open!"

Not the best policy even with guards outside, Jack thought as he entered the shuttle.

Carter smiled and nodded at him. "Sir."

"Hi, Jack!" Entrapta's greeting was as friendly as Hordak's was curt - the alien merely nodded at him.

"Hello… Oh, you're Colonel O'Neill!"

"Wow! Hello!"

Two men - two nerds - smiled at him. Jack raised his eyebrows. "And you are?"

"Oh, sorry! I'm Mark Bower; this is Gerald Cline. We're from NASA!"

"We heard that a shuttle set down here and decided to use the opportunity to see if we could talk to them - to the aliens," the other added.

"And you just walked up to the shuttle?" If that was true, heads would roll in the Pentagon. Jack would make sure of that.

"We wish!" Bower complained. "We had to go through security checks as if we were terrorists!"

“They even x-rayed us and our laptops! If we’d have sensitive equipment, that would have been damaged!” his colleague added.

Jack nodded. So, someone had greenlighted the ‘spontaneous’ visit. Probably some general who thought that Entrapta would react favourably to talking to those nerds. Well, it didn’t seem as if they had been wrong.

“And they have such interesting ideas!” Entrapta gushed. “I mean, we told people that we would offer travel to space, but with all the other negotiations we had to do, and the security concerns that Catra and Glimmer were talking about, we didn’t get anything done yet, but this! This is so much more interesting than some boring trip to space - we’ll be settling another planet in this star system and terraforming it! And without magic! Although…” She scrunched her nose. “Magic would speed up terraforming by a lot if we can get Adora to create some space plants on the planet. Or ask Perfuma if she can change plants to survive there.”

“As would self-replicating machinery,” Hordak added.

“That, too!” Entrapta nodded several times. Then she pouted. “But people here have hangups about self-replicating machines. Even though they could be soooo useful! And we’ve disproven the grey goo scenario that you mentioned. At least I think so.”

Bower and Cline nodded in obvious agreement with her, and even Carter didn’t look like she was opposing those plans with much fervour, Jack noted with a sinking feeling in his stomach. “Well,” he said, “we’ve had some bad experiences with nanites.” Namely, Jack himself. “Better safe than sorry.”

“But we wouldn’t use nanites!” Entrapta countered. “Well, not self-replicating nanites - we would use nanites to build micromachinery, of course. But we’re talking automated mining machines and factories. And if we can’t get Adora or Perfuma, probably rapid-growing plants that will turn the atmosphere breathable. As long as we can get exponential growth going, we’ll see Mars turning into another habitable world in our lifetimes!”

“The calculations work out!” Bower added. “All we need is transport capacity.”

“And perhaps some way to get a few ice asteroids to Mars,” Cline said.

Jack glanced at Carter and, once more, raised his eyebrows.

She blushed a little - which was a very bad sign. “Well, Sir, the concept sounds plausible. And the scientific and engineering challenges do not seem unsurmountable.”

“And it’s all civilian, non-military, so it shouldn’t be a problem for all the political stuff!” Entrapta added, beaming. Then she blinked. “Although I guess that someone would have to decide if Mars would be counted as part of Earth or not, and who gets to rule it.” She shrugged. “Well, that’s not a science problem.”

“But a pretty difficult political problem,” Jack said. What if they actually pulled it off, terraformed Mars and settled it, and then the planet decided to declare its independence? Would they throw instant coffee into the Sea of Dunes or something?

“Well, it’s a future problem - settlements would be small habitats for science,” Bower said. “And while we’d push them to become self-sustaining, they’d still be science outposts, not some… country.”

“And by the time there are enough people on Mars to form a country, we’ll probably have colonies on other planets thanks to the Stargates, so any political problem will have been solved already.” Cline smiled.

Jack frowned. “NASA sent you here to talk about colonising Mars?”

Bower coughed. “Ah, we were supposed to talk about chartering a transport to Mars - which we did - but once we got talking, well…” He smiled. “We quickly realised that we could do so much more!”

Jack grinned. The kid was too naive. With open war looming and the United States gearing up to produce spaceships as soon as the idiots in the Capitol managed to get their act together, the budget for terraforming Mars would be smaller than the budget for the design of the Space Force's unit patch.

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta nodded again. "This will be great! We'll have to do something about the lack of a magnetic field and the loss of the atmosphere, but that doesn't sound impossible to solve. Maybe an energy field to keep the atmosphere in and the solar wind out?"

Although, Jack realised, the Etherians might not quite share his view.

*****

Earth Orbit, September 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and as I said, Jesus Christ never condemned homosexuality; all the quotes people like to cite when they claim he was a homophobe are from the Old Testament."

"Thank you, Reverend, but last I checked, the Old Testament was still part of the Bible - the Word of God?"

"Oh, yes, technically. But a lot of the Old Testament is not part of Christian dogma. Last I checked, the Evangelicals haven't condemned spare ribs or pulled pork, have they? Or veal with cream sauce. Neither did they refrain from mixing fabrics. The Old Testament just isn't as important as what Jesus himself told us. And he never condemned homosexuality."

"But he valued the union between man and woman."

"That does not mean he condemned the union between man and man, or woman and woman. Jesus's message is one of love - not of homophobia. And he certainly didn't mean that whatever he didn't mention was to be condemned - that would hamper a lot of

televangelists since Jesus never said anything about television, either."

Adora frowned as Catra changed the channel to some music video. "Why would a god leave such a confusing book? Rules have to be clear; everyone knows that."

"Well, I like unclear rules; it makes breaking the rules without breaking them easier." Catra grinned.

"I bet you would." Adora snorted. Catra had never liked any rules that got in her way. "But at least it sounds better than what the others said."

Catra scoffed and shifted on her seat, twisting until she was watching the screen upside down. "When's Entrapta coming back?"

"The shuttle is on the way from Washington and will reach us shortly," Adora told her after a check with Darla.

"Ah." Catra reached over and changed the channel again.

"...the end times are coming! Rapture awaits us! God is…"

"...the Queen is expected to sign the acts at the first opportunity. A state visit by the Etherians has also been announced to celebrate the upcoming alliance even though several details have not been finalised and…"

"...protests by indigenous people in Brazil continue. They demand that the government contacts the Etherians and formally asks for magic to be returned to Earth. The Brazilian government has not yet commented on…"

"...casualties of the riots are estimated to reach over a hundred, and there is no sign of the riots ending…"

"...a mob demanding that the government in Tehran declare war on the Etherians has been forcefully dispersed, though rumours

about elements of the Revolutionary Guards refusing to obey orders continue to circulate…"

"...the Prime Minister, reportedly after consulting with representatives of the zaibatsu, addressed the Diet, stating that Japan's stance towards same-sex marriage has to be re-examined in light of the recent developments in Europe and expressed his hope that access to alien technology will revitalise Japan's economy. At the same time, Article 9 will have to be…"

"...the IDF has been put on alert as the border with Lebanon saw several skirmishes…"

"…Russia's president announced several emergency measures to stabilise the economy, blaming the war with the Goa'uld for the disruption and called on the Etherians to provide support…"

Adora blinked. "How are we supposed to help them?"

Catra shrugged. "I don't know. I'm a soldier, not a princess."

Adora frowned at her lover. "I'm a princess, and I don't know either."

"You don't have a kingdom to rule."

That was true. "We should ask Glimmer." Adora frowned. "But I think she has advisors for that." Glimmer hadn't talked a lot about economics - although she had mentioned the potential trouble if there was unrestricted trade between Earth and Etheria, hadn't she?

"Or Bow. He's got a brother who knows that stuff, doesn't he?"

Right, Count. But Adora had never met him, and he was on Etheria and not available. "Maybe we should… Oh!" She saw the shuttle approach them. "Entrapta and Hordak are coming."

"Good. Let's hope they haven't given the Americans a frigate or two."

Adora frowned at her lover as they left the bridge. Entrapta wasn't like that - and Catra knew it.

"I was joking," Catra said. "Besides, Hordak would never let her do that."

That was true. "Let's meet them and hear what happened in Washington."

"Virginia, actually."

Adora narrowed her eyes at Catra, who grinned. "Since when do you care about geography so much?"

"I read up on where the USA has its army headquarters, of course."

Of course.

But they had reached the hold and were just in time to see the shuttle set down on the deck.

"Adora! Catra! How was the meeting with the British kingdom?" Entrapta asked as she walked down the ramp, followed by Hordak.

"We only need to hash out a few more details and we have a second alliance ready to be signed," Catra replied. "They really want our tech."

"Everyone wants it!" Entrapta nodded. "Oh! We talked with NASA about terraforming - that means turning a planet into a second Earth or Etheria - the fourth and second planets of this system! It's so fascinating - they made plans without having the technology for it, but now that we're here, we should have the technology!"

"Ah." Adora smiled. "That's nice. How long would that take?"

“Oh, years and years! But it’s fascinating - and if it works here, we could, maybe, restore some of the planets Horde Prime destroyed.”

That had Melog, who had been dozing in the corner, perk up. Catra cocked her head to the side. “Melog would be interested in that.”

“I’m sure they would!” Entrapta grinned.

“I thought we’d restore their planets once I found out how to do it,” Adora said.

“Yeah, that was the plan, but if we can do it without magic, then everyone can do it!” Entrapta beamed. “It’ll take longer, but it’ll be so much more useful!”

“Right.” Adora wasn’t quite sure what to think about that. It felt… well, weird, not to be needed.

“Oh! Mark and Gerald - they’re from NASA - also told us about the smartest man on Earth! Stephen Hawkins! He’s dying from an illness. Can you help him? I think you could, couldn’t you?”

Adora blinked. That was…

“People are dying all the time,” Catra told her with a frown. “You can’t heal everyone, and if you start, you won’t be able to stop. I know you.”

“Yes. But this is an exception. He’s the smartest man on Earth!” Entrapta said.

“He should be useful for the war,” Hordak added. “And he is British, not American.”

Did that mean healing him fell under rendering critical assistance?

*****

Pentagon, United States of America, Earth, September 18th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So. Not only might we have inspired our alien mad scientist princess to create a green goo swarm and unleash it in our solar system, but we might also have asked them to reveal the full extent of their magic healing power to Earth by curing Hawkings. Not bad for an afternoon's worth of work. What's for tomorrow? Ask them to send missionaries of the Church of Adora to Earth?"

The Colonel's sarcasm was biting, but he wasn't entirely wrong; Samantha Carter knew it. But he wasn't entirely correct, either. "Sir, that was the result of NASA engineers meeting Entrapta. We couldn't exactly shoot them, and if we had ordered them to stay silent, this might have led to a diplomatic incident that would have undermined our efforts to win the trust of the Etherians." The Colonel had been present for half the meeting, after all.

"Well, we could shoot them now and make it look like an accident. I bet the NID could cover it up," the Colonel joked as he sat down in their temporary office in the Pentagon. Then he sighed. "Wrecking Mars and Venus isn't a big problem - it's not as if there's anything alive on those planets - even though the resources spent on terraforming them will be missing somewhere more important. But telling everyone that Adora can heal every illness with magic? Desperate people will hound her everywhere. And if she refuses to heal them, what will they do?"

"She might not be able to heal Dr Hawkins," Sam retorted. "We've only observed her healing wounds and counteracting poison." When Adora had saved the Colonel's life.

He raised his eyebrow at her. "You know what her magic did to my body. Do you really think she can't cure whatever Hawkins suffers from?"

"No, Sir." A scientist had to be honest.

“And if that ‘side-effect’ becomes known, what do you think will happen?” He cocked his head.

Everyone would want it. It wasn’t a true rejuvenation, but it was probably coming close. All the microdamage and lingering effects of wounds and broken bones healed? “They would be swamped with offers and demands.”

“Yes. Every rich old bastard will want to be ‘healed’. But what will the Etherians do?”

Sam pressed her lips together. That was the question. “I think Adora will have a hard time refusing to heal dying patients.” Especially if they were children.

“Yes. But she can’t heal everyone. And her friends won’t let her sacrifice herself like that,” the Colonel said. “And we need her for the war.” He leaned back and closed his eyes. “We need to talk to them about this. In secret.”

Sam nodded. “I’m sure we can arrange something, Sir.” It shouldn’t be hard - it was obvious that this had to be addressed.

“Without telling anyone.”

She blinked. Did he mean that not even their superiors would be informed?

“We need to talk to the Etherians before this spreads.” He looked around. “And if we tell anyone, it will spread.”

“The two engineers from NASA will not keep silent about this,” Sam pointed out. Not even if they asked or ordered them to stay silent - she knew the type.

“They’ll focus on the terraforming and colonisation parts. They’ll say they asked the Etherians to heal Hawkins, but they don’t know what the Etherians can do. And Entrapta only said she thought they could help.” He shook his head. “We can contain this, at least to some degree, if we act quickly.”

“Do you want to arrange a clandestine meeting?” That wouldn’t be too easy - anything related to the aliens was under close scrutiny by everyone - but if Sam called Entrapta, asked to do some experiments in space…

“Yes.” He suddenly grinned. “Let’s invite them to a movie night. Teal’c is dying to watch Star Wars with them.”

That was… well, that might actually work. She slowly nodded.

And the Colonel smiled widely at her. “You know what? Let’s make it a barbecue!”

*****

The Movie Night

Colorado Springs, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 19th, 1998

"I had expected something larger," Catra said after they had arrived at O'Neill's house. "This doesn't look like much." His car didn't have a minibar; another disappointment, but she had complained about that on the way already. She got out and stretched.

"Catra!" Adora hissed as she joined her.

"What? It's true! I expected something more impressive than a wooden hut." Catra sniffed.

"It's not a wooden hut!" Adora protested. "It's a… nice, little wooden house." She cocked her head and bit her lower lip. Anyone could tell that she was lying.

"It might not be much for a princess, but it's quite a nice house for Earth," O'Neill said. His smile showed a few too many teeth to be genuine, so Catra counted that as a win. Make her hide her tail, wear a stupid cap that squished her ears, would they?

"I still don't know why we can't just shoot anyone if they bother us," she muttered as the man opened the door to his house and ushered them inside. The interior looked as she expected from the shows she had seen. Which meant it wasn't impressive either.

"It's illegal," O'Neill told her as he closed the door. "I asked. Unless you're in Texas."

"We should hold this in Texas, then," Catra told him as she pulled the stupid cap off.

"Catra!" Adora hissed again.

“What? Do you know how uncomfortable this is?” Catra scowled at her, then pulled her tail out of her pants. “And if this fooled anyone, your spies are useless.”

“It’s not meant to fool spies,” O’Neill told her. “It’s meant to keep journalists from finding out about us.”

“Can’t we shoot them at least?” Catra said.

“Freedom of the press is a fundamental right in the United States.”

Ah, Daniel was already here. As was Teal’c. Catra glared at the latter - the ‘hat plan’ was probably his fault.

Not that the big man was fazed. He nodded at her and Adora. “Greetings. I am very happy that you will be finally enjoying one of the finest pieces of Tau’ri storytelling.”

“I’m sure George Lucas would be happy to hear this.” O’Neill grinned. Before he could say anything else, the doorbell rang. “It’s open!”

That would be Carter with Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta and Hordak. Catra couldn’t help laughing when she saw how they had ‘disguised’ Hordak - he was wearing a long coat with a high collar and a hat that hid everything else of his head. How he could see where he was going was anyone’s guess.

“Oh! Nice!” Entrapta looked around and beamed. “Is this a mobile house? Easy to disassemble, lightweight construction - do you fold it down for transport, or do you take it apart and then reconstruct it at the new location?”

“It’s not a mobile home. It’s a solid, perfectly fine American house,” O’Neill replied.

“Really? All the other buildings we saw were much more solidly built.” Entrapta cocked her head.

“It’s a solid *American* house,” O’Neill repeated himself.

“I think my claws would cut straight through it,” Catra said as she nosed around in the kitchen. “Do you have anything to drink?”

“Catra!”

“Beer and drinks are in the fridge.”

Oh! The fridge was stuffed with meat, a bowl of some vegetable dish and drinks! Catra grabbed a beer and threw it to Adora, then grabbed one for herself.

“Adora, don’t open it!” she heard Daniel yell.

“What? Why?”

“If you open it, it’ll spray beer all over you.”

“You just have to be careful,” Catra told them as she flicked her bottle’s cap off with her claws.

Adora scowled at her, then tried to open her bottle very carefully. She almost managed it but still needed a towel.

“Next time, aim the bottle at Catra,” Glimmer commented.

“And spill beer all over Jack’s house? I guess you never learned how to be a good guest,” Catra shot back.

“Oh!” Glimmer scowled as she grabbed a beer as well.

“I think I could build a safe beer opener,” Entrapta offered. “Do you have a workshop? And some spare engines?”

“Why don’t we move to the garden?” O’Neill told her. “The grill should be ready by now, and the grass won’t mind if you spill some beer, or coke, or anything else. And it’s hidden from view.”

“Alright!” Adora stood and headed out.

Catra finished her beer, then followed her and the others.

"You use… open fire to cook?" Hordak stared at the grill. "Is this some archaic ritual of hospitality?"

"Technically, it's not open fire - it's glowing coal," Entrapta told him. "But it was a fire first."

"How inefficient. And how do you control the temperature?"

"With great experience." O'Neill smiled rather toothily at Hordak. "And yes, it's a tradition in the United States."

"Well, there are some people who prefer electric grills," Daniel said. "Or gas."

"We don't speak about such blasphemy in this house." O'Neill frowned at him. "Without coal, it's not a barbecue."

"I think many would disagree about that, Jack. Gas grills are popular, and…"

Catra snickered as the two quarrelled, with Hordak giving his unwanted opinion every second sentence and Entrapta studying the grill. Maybe this would be more entertaining than she had expected.

*****

The nerve of some people! Gas grills! Electro grills! Jack O'Neill shook his head as he checked the heat on the grill - glowing coals, just as it was intended, thank you very much.

"I would have expected better of you, Daniel," he said, sighing as he took a step back. Time to grab the meat.

"What?" Daniel stared at him.

"I would have thought that you especially would be more respectful of my culture. Gas? Electro? Those are fighting words!"

“But…”

“So it is an archaic ritual of hospitality.” And the alien warlord had to comment with a nod. “That explains the stubborn refusal to change to more advanced heating techniques.”

Jack clenched his teeth as he stepped into his - perfectly solid and fine - house. He found Catra raiding his fridge for another beer. That was her… third? Jack hadn’t kept count.

She grinned as she opened it. “So, grill’s finally ready?”

“Yes.” He started grabbing the first course.

“About time.”

“A barbecue cannot be rushed,” he told her.

She shrugged. “I’m sure Entrapta would manage to do it if we asked her to.”

Jack shook his head. “The waiting and socialising is a crucial part of it.”

“And that’s why you had the fire prepared before we arrived?”

“One shouldn’t wait too long,” he said.

Catra made a snorting noise and took another sip from her bottle.

He couldn’t help it. “Shouldn’t overdo it,” he said. “You don’t want to become drunk early on.” Or at all. He had seen young soldiers indulge too much at the first opportunity, and they generally had had half again her weight.

“I need stronger stuff to get drunk,” she said. “Or more of this, but hogging all the beer would be rude.”

She didn’t offer to help him carry the meat. Jack wasn’t quite sure how to feel about that - he would, as host, have refused her help

anyway, but usually, people offered at least. Well, he certainly wouldn't comment.

A few minutes later, the meat was on the grill, and Jack joined the rest on the benches and lounge chairs in his garden. Catra was in Adora's lap, trying to fiddle with the blonde's top, while Adora tried to push her hands away without spilling her bottle. Entrapta was talking with Carter and Hordak about stuff that Jack didn't have to fake ignorance of, and Glimmer, Bow and Daniel were talking about history. With Teal'c - at least Jack's friend was nodding once to a comment of Daniel.

Jack almost felt bad for ruining the mood, but it was better to talk now, before everyone was buzzed and digesting large amounts of meat and watching Star Wars. He cleared his throat. "So, the first round should be ready in twenty or so." Plenty of time to discuss magical healing.

"Are you sure we can't use an accelerant to speed the cooking time up?" Entrapta asked. "Or cut the meat into tiny slices, which would cook faster?"

"Let's do it as the people here are used to," Glimmer told her. "They should know best since they have been doing this for a long time."

"Not so long - the country's barely two hundred years old," Bow commented, then grinned at the frown from Glimmer.

"Anyway," Jack raised his voice a little. "I wanted to discuss a thing. A potential problem."

"And you wanted to talk about it where we wouldn't be overheard by your superiors." Catra flashed her fangs in a wide grin. "I knew it! Pay up, Adora!" Well, Jack should have expected that she saw through his little ruse.

"We didn't make a bet! You just said you wanted to bet - I never agreed!"

Having them in a good mood is a good thing, Jack told himself as he cleared his throat again. "Well, yeah, it's a delicate topic. It's about healing. Magical healing. The thing you did to me when you saved my life."

"Oh?" Adora leaned forward, which made her put her chin on Catra's shoulder as the cat woman didn't move out of the way. "Were there complications? Do I need to heal you again?"

"No, no," Jack said. "Everything's fine. More than fine, actually - Dr Fraiser says my body's in peak condition, as good as a twenty-year-old's." Well, for a forty-year-old.

"Ah, good!" Adora beamed.

"Which is a problem," Catra said with a frown.

"What?" Adora gasped.

"A potential problem," Jack corrected her.

"You mean everyone will want to get healed," Glimmer said.

"More or less, yes," Jack said. "We've classified my medical information, so that should keep a lid on it." And he thought Fraiser might have gone the extra mile here. "But even if we manage to keep this detail secret, should you be able to heal Hawking, and I have no doubt that you could, you'll be swamped by the pleas of dying people all over the world. And people with incurable sicknesses." He didn't mention children. That would be counter-productive.

"Well, I can…"

"Six billion people's worth of terminal and incurable cases," Carter added, nodding at Adora.

"Oh." Adora closed her mouth.

"And professional athletes who want to get career-ending injuries healed." Daniel nodded. "Or just the rich and famous who want to skip weeks of rehab."

"You'd never have a minute's rest," Catra summed up.

"Well, I could just stick to the terminal people…" Adora bit her lower lip.

"Over a hundred thousand people die every day," Carter said. "Even if you healed one per second, you wouldn't be able to get them all."

"Oh."

*****

Over a hundred thousand people died every day! Adora hadn't considered just how many people lived on Earth. No, she couldn't heal so many people.

"Well, it would theoretically be possible if you had the ability to heal multiple people at once, but even then, you would need a way to gather all of them together, and that would require a huge logistical effort… Even with the whole fleet here, I'm not sure that we would manage to collect all of them…" Entrapta said.

"And you'd have to find them, first," Catra cut in.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "Although that could be solved with enough bots, provided we could whip up scanners for the vital signs of people. Perhaps if we had a transport system keyed to such scanners, and…"

"Are you talking about constructing a permanent round the clock surveillance system that monitors every human on Earth?" Sam asked.

Entrapta blinked. "Effectively, yes. If you want to heal everyone who's dying, then that's what you need. And a transport system to

match."

"And Adora not doing anything but healing the sick and wounded - not sleeping, not eating, not having fun with her friends, and not protecting anyone from the Goa'uld," Catra said with a scowl.

Adora winced. That sounded horrible. And not practical. But how could she be happy and have fun if people she could save were dying? How could she be so selfish? How could she… "Ow!"

Catra glared at her, her first - which had struck Adora's head - still raised. "Stop thinking stupid thoughts! You can't save everyone - and you can't save anyone if you kill yourself trying to save everyone! Have you forgotten your lessons about combat fatigue?"

"Of course not! If you are fighting, and even more if you are leading soldiers, you need you to be rested, or you'll make mistakes that might lose you the battle," Adora quoted from cadet training lessons.

"Same here, idiot - you can't heal everyone. You'll exhaust yourself long before you put a dent in all the sick and wounded," Catra said.

"Yes." Glimmer nodded with a very firm expression. "You couldn't heal every soldier in the Alliance, either, remember?"

"Well, no, but I was less experienced, and... OW!" Adora glared at Catra.

"I said no thinking stupid thoughts." Catra sniffed. "Besides, we need you in the war, not stuck on Earth exhausting yourself healing people who will be killed by the Goa'uld if we lose the war without you."

Adora opened her mouth to protest, but Bow cut her off: "Yes, Adora. You can't heal everyone, and you can do so much more. Besides, we can save more people if we teach them how to heal others. And improve their medical technology."

“As long as you don’t turn the sick into zombies,” Jack said. “I don’t think that would go over well.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “Proliferating healing technology should have a greater impact than Adora healing people - technology that anyone can use is always more effective than the efforts of single people, except for extraordinary circumstances.”

“And Earth magic should help as well,” Glimmer added. “Although teaching them decent healing spells would take years.”

“You would know, Miss Sparkly Staff Swinger,” Catra commented.

Adora pinched her. It wasn’t Glimmer’s fault that she hadn’t had the time to learn many spells.

“Ow!” But Catra was smiling at Adora.

“Anyway, yes, you can’t heal everyone,” Jack said.

“But that doesn’t mean I can’t heal anyone,” Adora protested.

“Dummy!” Catra frowned at her. “Didn’t you listen? If the people on Earth know that you can heal, they’ll mob you! They’ll beg and plead and bribe you to heal them or their loved ones. And you’ll have to tell them all no.”

That sounded… Adora clenched her teeth. “But I can’t just do nothing!”

“You have to,” Jack told her. “Unless you want to be worshipped as a goddess on Earth.”

”What?”

“Healing the sick? That’s pretty much part and parcel of the gods,” Jack explained.

“But…” Adora trailed off and sighed, wrapping her arms around Catra. “I don’t want to let people die. And Hawking…”

“Well, we could disguise the source of limited healing as ‘experimental technology’,” Sam suggested. “But that would have to be very limited.”

“Only those people whose continued existence would serve the war effort,” Hordak said. “This Hawking sounds like he could be useful.”

Adora glared at him. People shouldn’t get healed just because they were useful!

But Glimmer was nodding - and Bow was as well!

“That would work,” Glimmer said. “But not forever.”

“Well, we won’t stay on Earth forever,” Bow pointed out. “Once we’re back in space or on other planets, the problem, well, won’t go away but won’t be urgent.”

“Adora can’t be an idiot and kill herself healing others if there aren’t too many people to be healed,” Catra said.

“I’m not an idiot!”

“Yes, you are.” Catra grinned. “My idiot,” she added in a whisper.

Adora sighed, half-smiling against her will. Her friends wanted the best for her, and their arguments made sense, but… She hated letting people suffer when she could help. And when she couldn’t help. And yet… “Alright,” she mumbled.

“Finally!”

Catra didn’t have to sound so smug, Adora thought with a pout.

“And the first round of steak is done. Who wants one?” Jack announced.

“Me!” Catra wriggled out of Adora’s embrace before she could react. “Talking sense into Adora is hungry work!”

“Hey!”

*****

Samantha Carter had seen Star Wars before. Several times. She might not remember the whole movie verbatim, but she knew the plot very well, so she hadn’t expected to be entertained by watching it again.

But watching it with the Etherians wasn’t the same as watching it with the team.

“Oh! Bots! And look, a tiny bot! We need to build tiny bots!”

“They’re droids.”

“Thank you, Teal’c.”

“Blond, naive and has a magic sword? Hm… that sounds familiar!”

“I wasn’t a farmer. I was a cadet!”

“But… they’re torturing her!”

“And that is why you don’t talk if you’re going to kill someone.”

“Speaking from experience?”

“Their magic is lame.”

“Is this how Earth’s magic works?”

“That would still be lame.”

“They blew up the planet? Even after she told them what they wanted to know? They’re worse than Horde Prime!”

“We already knew that they’re evil, Adora.”

“But not how evil!”

“For supposed elite marksmen, those soldiers miss their targets far too often. At that distance, the two smugglers should be dead.”

“Perhaps that was their Kyle squad? Kyle platoon?”

“How could they just fly away in their ship? If I were in charge, the entire guard shift on the Death Star would be court-martialed!”

“Catra! That’s exactly what we did when we saved you from Horde Prime’s flagship. Ask Adora if you don’t believe me.”

“Ah, it was a trap! And they fell for it!”

“That happens when you don’t have sufficient ECM. This wouldn’t work with Darla - I made sure of that. Unless we encounter an enemy with better technology than we have and better magic, we won’t be tracked like that.”

“But I think this tactic might be useful when fighting the Goa’uld. Although arranging a convincing escape might be difficult without sacrificing a few soldiers.”

“Hordak! We don’t do that kind of thing!”

“I am aware. That is why I said it would be difficult.”

“Why doesn’t he get out and throw the blaster bolts back at the enemy with his sword?”

“Luke can’t jump through vacuum and cut ships apart, dummy!”

“He should be able to if he had a good spacesuit. I could build one with a jetpack!”

“They’re letting Luke fly a fighter without having any experience? He’ll crash it into the jungle!”

“He won’t. He’s a hero.”

“That doesn’t mean he can fly the thing. Remember how you crashed the skiff?”

“I didn’t crash it - you crashed it!”

“No, you!”

“That’s not how space combat works! Ships don’t fly that way! Although if we take the gravity caused by the Death Star’s mass into account… no, still doesn’t work!”

“It’s a movie, folks.”

“The flight characteristics of the X-Wings fighters, Y-Wing fighters and TIE-Fighters were modelled after Tau’ri atmospheric craft used in their greatest war, more than fifty years ago. It was a deliberate aesthetic choice.”

“Thank you, Teal’c.”

“I told you Han would be back! He’s a hero!”

“You didn’t! You were all mopey, Adora!”

“Luke is the hero. Han is a scoundrel. No wonder Adora likes him.”

“What do you mean, Glimmer?”

“Do I have to spell it out, Adora?”

“Hey! I wasn’t a smuggler - I was a soldier!”

“So was Han Solo. He was dishonourably discharged after he helped Chewbacca.”

“Thank you, Teal’c.”

“Look at those torpedoes! They are super-agile - we need that as well!”

“They would need inertial compensators to be able to pull such manoeuvres. That would reduce their payload.”

“We could make them bigger to compensate.”

“Yes! There goes the Death Star!”

“I would court-martial the designer. And everyone involved in its construction. How could you build something with such an obvious weak spot?”

“Well, if this was the first Death Star they built, it was kind of a prototype, and such mistakes are expected. I had a lot of prototypes when I built bots.”

“Why didn’t Chewbacca get a medal?”

“The Princess was too small to put it on him.”

“Catra!”

“She could have used a droid for that. I would have used my hair - and I think her hair would be long enough if it were magical.”

Indeed, Sam thought as the credits appeared on the screen, this was a very entertaining experience.

The Colonel clapped his hands. “So, what do you think?”

Catra shrugged. “Not bad.”

“Not bad?” Glimmer scoffed. “You were glued to the screen! You almost tore my head off when I talked in that scene!”

“So?”

“You loved it, didn’t you?” Glimmer smirked.

Catra glared at her.

Adora coughed. “Well, it was a little… strong, in places.”

Sam clenched her teeth. The Etherians had lived through similar situations - and the science fiction setting with fantasy elements including a princess would only make it look more, not less realistic. Her team hadn't thought about that.

"I found it very inspiring," Entrapta said with a smile.

"Indeed," Teal'c agreed. "A few brave warriors fighting an evil Empire and winning against the odds - anyone would be inspired by this tale."

"I was more inspired by the technology!" Entrapta corrected him. "I've got so many new ideas!"

"Dibs on a lightsaber," Catra said.

"You want a sword?" Adora asked with a surprised expression.

"No, a lightsaber."

"Well, it should be possible, theoretically. But the power requirements would limit its use. Or make it too heavy to be used easily. And probably make it explode if it gets hit. Still… I think I could build one."

"Really?"

Sam blinked. How many had just said that?

*****

"Lightsabers are just laser swords. Sea Hawk has one."

Catra scoffed at Glimmer's claim. "That's not the same. Sea Hawk has a sword with a blade that can glow. But that's not a blade made out of energy. Or do you see Luke polishing his blade like Sea Hawk does?"

All her friends gave her a strange look. Catra rolled her eyes. "Not *that*."

Adora blushed in that cute. flustered way of hers. “Sorry…”

“You are correct,” Entrapta said. “Sea Hawk’s sword isn’t a lightsaber. Although I think it could be upgraded to offer similar functionality - though with some of the same issues as a lightsaber would have. The power demands would be much greater, which would cause some of the same issues, although you wouldn’t need the same focusing and limiting mechanism. If you use the blade as a medium, you don’t need an energy field to contain the plasma.”

“So, it would still explode if it were hit?”

“Yes,” Entrapta said. “The energy density of the power supply would just be too high to avoid that - unless you only want to use it for a few minutes.”

“That wouldn’t be enough for a battle,” Catra said.

“Why would you need a lightsaber, anyway?” Daniel asked. “You have a magic sword. Or claws that can cut through armour.”

“It is an elegant weapon of a more civilised age,” Teal’c said. “I would like to use such a weapon in battle.”

“But that wouldn’t leverage your advantages in strength and mass,” Glimmer pointed out.

“When facing other Jaffa, I may not have such advantages,” Teal’c retorted.

“And it’s a cool weapon!” Bow gushed. “I wonder if I could make lightarrows.”

“Oh! They wouldn’t have to be active for long - and exploding if containment is breached would be a bonus!” Entrapta said.

“But in order to get a significant blast out of a power cell, you’d have to make the arrow rather heavy,” Hordak said.

“Unless we used anti-gravity generators.”

“Are you planning to use a trebuchet to shoot the bolt?” Catra pointed out.

“No!” Bow said.

“That would be… no?” Entrapta looked disappointed.

“You know, the cultural impact of Star Wars is much greater than the inspirations for weapons. Or it should be,” Daniel commented with a frown. “The themes of the movie resonated with a lot of people who would have dismissed a mere science fiction movie. Some consider it a fairy tale set in space. You know, with princesses, knights, dark lords…” He trailed off, looking a little sheepish. “I mean, for Earth, before we made contact with you, it was a fairy tale.”

“Way to go, Daniel,” O’Neill muttered under his breath, and the man blushed a little.

Catra cleared her throat. She had no intention to go over all the ‘themes’ - the Evil Empire already made her remember things she didn’t like to think about. Like her life in the Horde. “So, how about we watch the next movie?”

“Right.”

Good. Catra smiled and settled down on the carpet, leaning against Adora’s legs, as Teal’c swapped the cassette for another.

“The next movie is widely seen as the best of the trilogy,” Daniel commented.

Well, Catra thought, that remains to be seen.

“What a cute bot! Oh, no - they shot it!”

“This is a very effective strategy for automated interstellar recon. If we flood the enemy’s system with stealth bots, the intel this

would produce… the technological challenges would be easily met if we manage to miniaturise the FTL communication array…”

“Oh, no! The poor tauntan!”

“It’s just a dumb animal. It’s not as if he cut open Swift Wind, Adora.”

“But it’s so cruel! It carried him through the storm, to Luke, did its best, and now he kills it?”

“It would have died anyway.”

“He just choked the man to death?”

Catra resisted the urge to reach for her own throat as she remembered almost suffocating when Hordak punished her.

“That’s a very drastic way to deal with failure. Although I can understand the feeling.”

“Hordak!”

Catra didn’t look at him as Adora protested. She had gotten him back, anyway. Beat him. Not that it mattered in the end.

“Did you never want to kill a subordinate that made such a huge blunder in the Alliance?”

“Of course not! Right, Glimmer?”

“Shh. The invasion starts.”

“Glimmer?”

“Shh!”

“Imperial walkers? Oh!”

“Don’t tell me you’re planning to build those!”

“What? No. Too unstable. And too slow. But they look nice! Perhaps we could build them as tiny bots?”

“Well, that was to be expected. If you have lower numbers and lower firepower, don’t get into static battles.” Catra scoffed.

“They had to gain time for the others to evacuate!”

“Should have had a better plan. Like buried explosives. Or decent artillery. They didn’t even have good fixed defences. Hell, if they were about to sacrifice the troops anyway, strap them in those speeders, fill it up with a bomb and ram the walkers.”

“Catra!”

“What?” The tactics shown weren’t good. Anyone could see that.

“That’s a very, very dense asteroid field. It must have been very recently formed, or it would have spread out - the Empire must have blown up a planet in the system! They have another Death Star!”

“I think they would need space suits for this, not just breathers. Unless this cave has an atmosphere somehow. Magic?”

“That’s a huge monster. A really huge monster.”

“I could take it. I think.”

“You’re She-Ra.”

“Well, a sufficiently big bomb would kill the monster - especially if it swallows it without digesting it.”

“Ew. Look at that swamp! Can you imagine the smell of it?”

“Yes, Glimmer.”

“Oh, no, R2-D2!”

“That is Yoda?”

“It might just be a spy for the real Yoda. Like Hordak’s spy.”

“He reminds me of Madame Razz.”

“Ugh, you’re right, Adora.”

“Vader? Here?”

“Yes! Off with his head!”

“Bah! That was just a dream!”

“I don’t trust that guy.”

“You don’t trust anyone.”

“He’s too… see? He’s a traitor!”

“Oh, no! How could they do this?”

“See? She loves him, not Luke! The scoundrel wins!”

“That doesn’t look like winning, Catra.”

“Well, it seems a rather ineffective alternative to stasis pods. Although the energy demands over time might be low enough to make it a better long-term storage method.”

“We’re not going to freeze people, Entrapta!”

“See? He wasn’t a traitor!”

“He was a double traitor!” Like Double Trouble.

“You tell him, Luke! You…”

“…”

“Impossible! He can’ be Luke’s father!”

“Why would he cut off his son’s hand? It must be a lie!”

"Why would he lie about this? And why would he make up such a lie?"

"I don't believe that Obi-Wan lied to Luke!"

Well, Catra could believe that. Very well. She glanced at Adora, who had a grim expression as well. Both knew about lying… people who raised you. Hordak looked grim as well - he would, of course.

And that was supposed to be the best movie of the trilogy? Who wanted to watch the heroes lose?

*****

"Well, now we absolutely have to watch the next movie!"

Jack O'Neill agreed with Adora's outburst. Not because he wanted to watch the movie - Teal'c was already moving - but he didn't want the Ethrians to dwell on the downer ending for too long. It was obvious that the movie hit quite a few of their buttons. The way Catra had almost touched her own throat when that Imperial Captain had been strangled, and the reaction to Darth Vader's revelation… Well, Jack had already known that they had some issues with betrayals. And he could definitely tell that 'need to know' would have to be carefully managed should they form an alliance with the United States - they wouldn't accept being kept out of the loop. Fortunately, they were all leading members of the Princess Alliance, so they should have the necessary clearances.

"Yes, I concur," Teal'c said. "While many consider 'The Empire Strikes Back' the best Star Wars movie, it does not have a happy ending. Although this follows the classic structure of a tale - the second act is often focused on challenges and problems before the third act offers the solution."

Teal'c's English lessons obviously had covered literature in more depth than Jack had expected.

“Way to spoil the ending!” Catra complained with a scowl. Although it looked a little fake to Jack. And Adora was clearly relieved there would be a happy ending. Same for Bow and Glimmer.

Well, they were all kids. Except for Hordak, and Jack didn’t care about him, and Entrapta, who often acted like a kid. A kid who could nuke a country or planet if an experiment went wrong.

He opened another beer while the opening began.

“See! They have a second Death Star! That’s where the asteroid field came from!”

“No, this is a different system.”

“The Emperor is even eviler than Darth Vader?”

“Of course he is! Darth Vader would have killed him otherwise!”

“All that sand can’t be good for the poor bots!”

“They are called droids in Star Wars.”

“The sand is still not good for them. I hope they have enough lubricants.”

“He just gave them to that… slug? Without even telling them? But… how could he be so cruel!”

“Well, did you see his clothes? He went all dark. Pretty sure he joined his father.”

“Catra! They wouldn’t have skipped that! And Luke wouldn’t do that!”

“They could use a flashback to show it! And he just handed over the bots to Jabba!”

“I’m sure he has a good reason for it!”

“Dream on, Adora!”

“Shh!”

“Sorry!”

“Shh!”

“It… ate her. They fed the girl to a monster!”

“They shouldn’t be trying to make a bargain with the slug! Just kill the real monster!”

“Oh, no! They captured Chewbacca!”

“That bounty hunter is crazy!”

“Or he’s bluffing. But whether he was bluffing or crazy, it worked!”

“Oh! It’s Leia! She went in to save her love!”

“Did you expect her to wait until Luke the Dark bought him?”

“Oh, no!”

“How dumb was that? Didn’t she have anyone to watch her back? She makes Alliance missions look good!”

“Hey!”

“You know it’s true!”

“Well, you did forget me once…”

“Those were special circumstances.”

“Oh no! Poor Leia!”

“Well, that’s a better costume than her armour.”

“Catra!”

“Don’t tell me it’s not hot!”

“Slave Princess Leia is one of the most iconic visuals of the trilogy. Many fans love it and don similar costumes for events. It is also said to feature heavily in many teenage fantasies.”

“Thank you, Teal’c.”

“We should buy a set for Adora. I bet she’d look great in it!”

“Catra!”

“What? You would!”

“Oh, no - Luke is getting eaten by the monster!”

“Big loss.”

“Oh no… that poor monster. Look at the man crying!”

“The monster ate the other girl.”

“But it didn’t know better. It’s all the fault of Jabba!”

“Yes! And he tortures bots!”

“Robots are called droids in Star Wars.”

“Oh! This must be magic - you wouldn’t survive for a thousand years in its belly otherwise!”

“Why didn’t anyone just drop a bomb down its maw?”

“So they won’t kill the victims, duh!”

“Can they get them out?”

“They… Yes! Lightsaber time!”

”And there’s the double traitor - is that triple traitor now?”

“And down goes the bounty hunter! Bon appetit!”

“Hah! Die, Jabba, die!”

“Killed by his own foolishness. He should have known better than handing his slaves such a handy weapon.”

“Or he should have had better guards. I would have killed all of them myself for letting him out of their sights.”

“Oh, the Emperor is small.”

“And not wearing armour. That is foolish.”

“He’s got thousands of guards.”

“They could easily betray him. Personal armour is of crucial importance.”

“You would say that, of course.”

“Darth Vader is his father!”

“How could they have lied to him?”

“They didn’t tell him about his sister?”

“They separated them?”

“How cruel!”

“Those are supposed to be the good guys?”

“Leia is his sister? What?”

“Ew!”

“No wonder she loves Han.”

“Ew.”

Jack swallowed a comment. Yes, the Etherians didn't deal well with deceptions and betrayals.

"Han volunteered? Must still have brain damage from the freezer."

"He's a hero!"

"He should know better than trusting those kinds of plans."

"We need such bikes!"

"Catra! You just saw how dangerous they are!"

"Doesn't matter. We need such bikes. For… scouting or something."

"Bow! Not you too!"

"Cannibal furballs? Why doesn't Luke kill the monsters?"

"But they look cute!"

"And want to grill Han alive."

"Well…"

"What's Luke doing? He's acting like Adora!"

"Hey!"

"Well… he is?"

"Bow!"

"It's a trap! It's a trap!"

"Indeed."

"Those stormtroopers are garbage! Getting beaten by a few furballs with sticks and stones? Even Kyle would have done better than that!"

“Definitely.”

Jack really needed to meet this Kyle.

“And the shield is gone! Bye-bye Death Star!”

“Luke’s still on it!”

“Luke chose to head there.”

“Hah! Die, Emperor, die!”

“A fitting end for him.”

“Adora?”

“Uh, yes, a fitting end.”

“That reminds me of…”

“We know, Entrapta.”

“Oh, no… Darth Vader is dying?”

“Come on, heal him - use the force, Luke!”

“He can’t heal him? Didn’t they teach him anything?”

“And there is no spare armour. That’s not good planning.”

“Well… that’s a happy ending, I guess.”

“Darth Vader looks harmless without his armour.”

“Indeed. He has become a force ghost.”

“Ah.”

The Etherians were rather subdued after the end credits started to roll, Jack noticed. Perhaps they should have picked another movie for this occasion.

*****

“So… I guess that was a happy ending,” Adora said. All but Vader lived, but…

“You guess?” Catra raised her eyebrows, and her ears perked as she grinned at Adora.

“Well… It’s commonly seen as a classic happy ending,” Daniel said.

He had been unusually silent during the movies, Adora realised. He hadn’t said even nearly as much as Teal’c. Was he not feeling well or something? Should she offer to heal him? Or was this some cultural taboo that she and her friends had just broken? Sam and Jack hadn’t said much, either. And all three looked… concerned. Even tense. “Uh… should we have stayed silent during the movie?” she asked.

“What?” Now Daniel looked confused.

“Did we break a rule?” Adora explained.

“I think I remember something about shutting up in the theatre,” Catra said. “But that’s boring.”

“Ah… technically, this isn’t a theatre,” Daniel said.

So, they should have stayed silent. “Sorry.” Adora sighed.

“No, no - this is a private viewing!” Daniel quickly told her. “Reacting to the movie is perfectly acceptable. Especially amongst friends.” He nodded several times.

“Ah.”

“And you can observe our reactions better if we don’t stay silent.” Catra snorted and grinned, but there was an edge to her comment.

Daniel blushed a little. “Well, uh, I couldn’t not observe your reactions.”

They had been a little loud, hadn’t they? Adora felt her cheeks heat up. “Sorry.”

“Don’t be sorry - this isn’t a theatre full of hardcore fans,” Jack said.

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded. “There is nothing wrong with expressing your passion when watching Star Wars.”

“In private,” Jack added.

They hadn’t denied that they had observed their reactions.

“Anyway,” Daniel went on, “the ending does match all the criteria for a classic happy ending. The protagonists survived, the hero and the heroine got together, evil was vanquished and justice and peace restored.”

“Luke didn’t get the girl, though,” Catra said, grinning. “Then again, that would’ve been awkward.”

“Catra!” Adora pouted at her lover.

“You’re just annoyed that Luke wasn’t the hero of the story.”

“He so was!” Adora retorted.

“Arguably, Luke’s the protagonist - we see his journey from farm boy to Jedi Knight,” Daniel said. “A classic hero’s journey.”

“He is the hero destined to overthrow the evil empire and redeem his father,” Teal’c commented.

“He’s boring. Han’s exciting. And sexy. Ask Leia.” Catra was just trying to rile her up, Adora knew it. Then again, the movies had had scenes that cut a bit too close.

She glanced at Hordak and Entrapta. Hordak must have realised the parallels between Darth Vader and himself, down to the armour keeping them alive. But unlike Hordak, Darth Vader hadn't survived. And Entrapta couldn't have missed that, either. The two were huddled together, too, staring at…

…Entrapta's device? And discussing something?

"They're talking about new bots," Catra whispered as she slid into Adora's lap.

"Oh." Still, the movie had affected them. As it had Adora. Luke… there was just something to his 'journey'. Finding the sword of his father, facing the evil Darth Vader, trying to learn how to use his powers… Adora knew how that felt like. Being lied to by your mentor - she also knew exactly how that felt. And losing your… well, Shadow Weaver wasn't Darth Vader, but she had died in a similar way. Was Luke as conflicted about his father's death? Was he relieved as well, partially at least? And as ashamed to feel that way?

Of course, it could have been worse. Much worse. Shadow Weaver had been… Shadow Weaver. Adora remembered how she had felt on Horde Prime's flagship, holding Catra's lifeless body after that fall, thinking she had lost everything.

She wrapped an arm around Catra's waist and pulled her closer. She wouldn't lose her. She'd die before she would let that happen. Again.

"So, that's your favourite movie, Teal'c?" Bow asked,

"No, he hates it and just… Hey!" Catra started to say, but Adora interrupted her by bending forward and nuzzling her ear.

"Let it go," she whispered.

Catra wriggled in her lap in response and pouted but didn't needle Bow.

“It is an epic tale of heroism and triumph against evil,” Teal’c said. “A corrupt Empire built on lies brought down by bravery and cunning. What better inspiration could you seek for our own struggle against the Goa’uld?”

“Well, I hope we won’t have to cut it as close as the rebels did,” Glimmer said. “And with a better plan.”

“And more firepower,” Catra added.

And without losing any of my friends, Adora thought.

“Well, the situation for us is different,” Sam said. “We - if we combine our forces - have technological superiority and better doctrines for both space and ground fighting. And the Goa’uld are far less united than the Empire.”

“Because we killed Ra a few years ago.” Jack grinned. “They’re busy stabbing each other in the back to see who gets the throne. But that window of opportunity won’t last forever.”

“Which is why we will strike as soon as possible,” Glimmer said, nodding. “Once we solidify alliances and gather enough ground troops, we can go on the offensive.”

Uh.oh. Adora knew where this was headed - and she didn’t want to talk about politics or war. Not now. “So, did they make more movies?” she asked Teal’c. Catra snorted, but Adora didn’t care that her attempt to change the subject was obvious.

“A few spin-offs,” Daniel said. “But they were not, well…” He shrugged. “Not the same quality. And there are comics, novels and games. They are making a new movie - a prequel - but I think they stopped production and are considering redoing it or something.”

“And don’t forget the TV Christmas special!” Jack grinned.

Teal’c glared at him. “We do not talk about the Christmas Special.”

*****

Spooks Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 20th, 1998

"...and we need to do this again! Bye!"

"Bye! Drive… fly responsibly!"

"Of course!"

Samantha Carter watched as the shuttle lifted off and flew into orbit, suppressing the slight envy she felt at the reminder that for the Etherians, flying into space was as easy - or easier - than driving home after work.

"Well, that's it." The Colonel sighed and turned back to look at Sam and her friends. "Mission accomplished. I guess."

"Mission?" Daniel blinked.

"To keep Adora from causing chaos by offering magical healing to Earth," the Colonel reminded him.

"Ah, yes." Daniel nodded. "I was more concerned with their reactions to Star Wars."

"We noticed," Sam told him.

He smiled a little sheepishly. "It's fascinating. An advanced civilisation, reacting to Earth's pop culture. I mean… we haven't seen that before. Even contact with Abydos wasn't like… well, we didn't have much in the way of pop culture to show. I did tell a lot of stories, but telling the plot of Star Wars isn't the same as watching the movie." His smile turned both sad and wistful.

Sam suppressed a wince. He would be thinking of his wife.

“The visuals are striking, even for someone used to space flight, but the story itself is its strength,” Teal’c said.

“Not everyone agrees, Teal’c,” the Colonel told him. “For many critics, as soon as people have ray guns, it’s just cheap entertainment, not cultured.”

“It seems those people value appearances over substance,” Teal’c said. “Therefore, their opinions are highly suspect.”

“Yeah, I’d say so too. Many of them would probably claim Hockey isn’t the best sport ever, either.” The Colonel grinned.

“Jack…” Daniel sighed. “Well, they liked Star Wars. I don’t think they were just being polite.”

Sam nodded. She didn’t think Catra would even consider lying just to be polite. “Yes.”

“But we kind of screwed up as well,” the Colonel went on. “We forgot that for them, Star Wars is like watching a war movie for veterans. A contemporary war movie.”

Sam winced. They should have considered that.

Daniel nodded, but Teal’c frowned. “What do you mean, O’Neill?”

“The movies made them think of things they didn’t want to think about. A number of those scenes were probably a little too close to what they lived through,” he explained.

“Yes,” Daniel agreed. “No one triggered, but… we should have considered that an evil Lord of the Sith in a suit of armour that doubles as a life support system would remind Hordak about, well, himself.”

“Well, I was more concerned about the whole betrayal thing in the movies,” the Colonel said. “Hordak is a big former warlord and can handle himself.”

“I wouldn’t be so sure about that, Sir,” Sam objected. “He was raised in very… unique circumstances. They all were, compared to the average American soldier.”

“And they are stronger for it,” Teal’c said, nodding slowly but firmly. “They faced the worst and were not broken. And those of them who served a false god refuted him. Like Vader ultimately refuted the Emperor.”

Just like Teal’c.

“Well, yeah, but they didn’t die like Vader,” the Colonel said. “And even if they won, not many want to be reminded of what they did and lived through in a war.”

Sam nodded again and suppressed a sigh at Teal’c’s expression. For all their friendship, and his interest in Earth culture and customs, Teal’c still was a Jaffa, with all that entailed.

“Why wouldn’t they want to remember their deeds? They fought a tyrant and won. This is something to be proud of - and to tell others to teach and inspire them.”

“Well, they’re still kids,” the Colonel said. “And yes, Entrapta isn’t a kid, but she’s… Entrapta. So, we can’t treat them like Jaffa.”

“I think they could do with some therapy,” Daniel said. “Especially if the war with the Goa’uld starts for real.”

“Yeah, getting them therapy might be a tad difficult,” the Colonel said, grimacing. “You don’t send your absolute monarch to a shrink. And you absolutely don’t send an absolute monarch of a foreign country to a shrink.”

“Well, they’re an advanced society; I think they have their own… therapists,” Daniel said.

“You think? Or you hope?” The Colonel raised his eyebrows.

"It's not a topic that came up so far in our talks," Daniel replied. "But I'll have to ask them about it. This could have consequences for the war efforts."

"Just be very… diplomatic," the Colonel told him. "We're already on thin ice with the whole gay marriage thing. If they think we consider them crazy, it might kill the alliance."

"I think you overestimate the problem, O'Neill, and underestimate our friends' strength. Honesty is the best policy, as they said themselves. Just voice your concerns in a straightforward manner." Teal'c nodded at them.

"Easier said than done," Daniel muttered.

Sam resisted the urge to bite her lower lip. She was an officer in the Air Force, not a teenager faced with a row in the family. "I could ask Entrapta about… talking to people," she offered.

"Good idea. I don't think Entrapta will get mad," the Colonel said, nodding. After a moment, he demonstratively yawned. "But we better get home now. It's past midnight, and we'll have a long day tomorrow, what with all the debriefings and reports about tonight."

Oh, yes. Sam clenched her teeth.

"This was a private affair, Jack," Daniel said with a frown. "Our reports should say so." Sam could hear the 'and nothing else' as if he had said it.

"Yeah. I'm not saying we should rat them out. But we have to let Hammond know about the healing thing. And that they like Star Wars. And warn the brass about pushing their buttons." The Colonel snorted. "And that they absolutely hate being lied to."

That was true. But Sam was sure that the Etherians didn't like being spied on, either. And they would see revealing what was said tonight as breaking their confidence.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 20th, 1998

Catra leaned back into her cushion - for all her muscles, Adora was quite soft when you knew where to sit and were flexible enough - and sighed as they approached Darla. "So… how much intel do you think did we let slip to SG-1?"

"Catra!" Adora blurted out. "This was a movie night! They didn't spy on us!"

Catra snorted. Adora was great - brave, kind, forgiving, loving, protective, honourable, incredible in bed - but she was trusting to a fault. "They only had to keep their eyes and ears open as we watched the movie." And she was sure neither O'Neill nor Daniel had missed anything.

"But that doesn't mean they would use that against us!" Adora retorted. "They're our friends!"

"Yes," Glimmer chimed in. "But they're also loyal towards their country."

"Well," Bow spoke up, "I don't think they would attempt to use what they know about us against us, but what about using it to, ah, better understand us?"

Catra snorted again. "You mean, use their knowledge of us to help them plan how best to make a deal with us?"

"Err… it sounds bad if you say it like that." Bow pouted.

Glimmer, though, nodded at Catra. "Exactly."

"They know how to make a deal with us!" Adora, predictably, protested. "We told them what we want! Equal rights for everyone!"

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “But the American president might think that if he knows more about us, we’ll compromise on that.”

Catra nodded. That would fit what they knew about the American government. Or any Earth government.

“Well, then them knowing more about us is a good thing,” Adora said. “So they’ll know we won’t. Compromise, that is.”

“They’ll still attempt to find leverage. Even if they manage to fulfil our conditions - or especially if they do and an alliance is formed. They want to have as much influence in the alliance as possible,” Hordak said.

Catra nodded again.

And, once more, Glimmer agreed. “That’s how it works back home as well.”

“But…” Adora frowned at them. She probably would have jumped up and crossed her arms if Catra hadn’t occupied her lap. “Our friends don’t think like that!”

“Well…” Glimmer took a deep breath. “Not our close friends, I think.”

Adora looked at her as if she had been told that she would not be allowed to eat anything but Horde rations for a month. Or a year. “But…”

“Adora,” Catra told her. “Yes, our close friends won’t stab us in the back or play political games with us. They fought with us, and they know what was and is at stake.” And just how powerful She-Ra was. “But the people on Earth? Their rulers? They don’t. They don’t know us.”

“And for them, that’s normal. Politics,” Glimmer added.

“Yes.” Bow nodded. “I’ve read up on their history, and their alliances were full of power struggles and politics. Sometimes

even between people of the same country. Fellow soldiers."

"That was normal in the Horde - my Horde; not Horde Prime's," Hordak said.

He was glancing at her, Catra noticed. She bared her fangs in a grin in return. They understood each other.

"So, you think SG-1 will tell them… that we liked the movies?" Adora asked. "Or will they tell them how we reacted?"

Catra shrugged. "Hard to say." O'Neill was the kind of man to do what he thought was necessary, no matter what. But what would he think was necessary? That was the big question. Teal'c, though, she was sure wouldn't betray their confidence. Sam and Daniel... Sam would follow O'Neill's lead. Daniel would do what he thought was right. He wouldn't betray them.

"I think they'll be fine," Entrapta said. "And even if they tell them what we thought of the movies, so what? It's not a secret." She beamed. "There were so many neat ideas! I can't wait to start doing science!"

That was… well, not entirely true, but Entrapta was right that even if the Americans got the full records of the evening, they wouldn't really gain much that they hadn't already known. "Well, not so for their magic. It sucked."

Adora nodded.

"Yoda managed to lift the entire X-Wing," Bow pointed out.

"Big deal," Adora said. "I can do the same without magic. And so could Scorpia."

Catra chuckled. "But you'd be all dirty afterwards."

"And anti-gravity generators could do the same as well," Entrapta added. "Luke should have left them on, anyway, when he landed in a swamp."

"Yeah, that was dumb. But that's Luke for you. All brawn, no brains."

"Hey!" Adora pouted at her.

Catra grinned back. "I wasn't talking about you."

"I know what you meant!"

Catra let her tail rub against Adora's nose, and when her lover gripped it and was distracted, Catra leaned in and planted a kiss on her lips.

"Mhh."

Cara closed her eyes and enjoyed the kiss. That was how a relaxed evening should end.

"Oh, for… at least wait until we're back inside Darla!" Glimmer complained.

Catra ignored her. No one kept Glimmer from kissing Bow.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 20th, 1998

"We need more details, Colonel O'Neill. This is of crucial importance." Smith - if that was the man's real name, Jack O'Neill would eat his service cap - frowned. Jack had the impression he didn't really believe that Jack didn't remember many details.

Well, Jack didn't care. He hated spooks as much as he hated politicians. Perhaps a little bit more since he had worked far more often with spooks than with politicians in the past. "I told you that they seemed to like Star Wars but also that it seemed to remind them of their own war."

“Yes, but which scenes, in particular, did remind them of their own war? We cannot build a dependable psych profile if we can’t pinpoint the exact triggers.”

Which was part of the reason Jack wasn’t going to tell the man any details. Shrinks ranked third on his list, after all. Second on any day that he had a mandatory counselling session scheduled. “I also told you that the revelation that Obi-Wan and Yoda had lied and kept the truth about Luke’s family from him struck them hard. That kind of manipulation seemed to rile up all of them.”

“Yes, you did. But we need more data.”

The guy sounded like a suited version of Entrapta without her charm and innocence. No, like a druggie suffering withdrawal. And Jack didn’t want to sell out his friends to get the guy his fix. “Did it occur to you that if you build up your psych profile and then try to ‘handle’ the Etherians, they will notice that?”

“I doubt that, Colonel.” The man’s bland smile grew a tad more arrogant.

Jack clenched his teeth. “You’re still thinking that the Etherians are kids from a fantasy land, aren’t you?”

“We’re aware that they have fought a war and have access to advanced technology.”

Damn. Jack hoped that the man’s superiors were more on the ball. “You don’t get it. They aren’t young people in over their heads. They aren’t traumatised kids you can manipulate with a lollipop and a smile. They rule their own countries.” Well, some of them did. “They’re leading armies and fleets. And they have experience with politics and war.”

“Only two of them are ruling princesses, and Entrapta has shown a marked reluctance to engage in politics which points to a lack of experience - something which was corroborated with information you provided.”

Oh, for crying out loud! "All of them have command experience at the highest level. They have been leaders of a coalition of sovereign rulers. It's all politics at that level." One of the reasons Jack was happy as an officer in the field. "Stop thinking of them as naive kids! Think of them as presidents and four-star generals."

"You're not an analyst, Colonel O'Neill."

"And you're not in charge of US politics," he shot back. "You don't understand the difference between naive and principled. You think because they don't give a damn about the 'realities' of American politics, they are ignorant." The man's glare told him he was on the mark. "They know how the USA works. They know the limits of our system." Daniel certainly had taught them more than enough about that on the way back.

"If they do, they don't really show it," the man fired back.

"They don't have to," Jack spat. "They don't need us. We need them."

"And that is why we need more intelligence about them, Colonel!"

*****

"I think Star Wars has been ruined for me!" Jack O'Neill exclaimed as he sat down at SG-1's table in the cantine.

"Why would that be, O'Neil?" Teal'c asked.

"Didn't you get debriefed about the trilogy?" Jack asked as he poked the 'food' on his tray. Just to check if it was still alive. Not that it looked as if it had ever been alive.

"I was happy to explain the intricacies of Star Wars to the agent," Teal'c said without changing his expression. "At length."

Which meant that he had drowned the interrogator in movie trivia and hadn't said much if anything about the Etherians. Jack snorted.

“I explained the unique opportunity of watching people from a society without movies to that kind of media,” Daniel added. “Well, a society without movies but with the cultural background to understand Star Wars.”

“I stuck to technical aspects of hypothetical Star Wars technology reproduced with current technology,” Carter said in a bland voice.

“I guess I should have stuck to military tactics seen through Star Wars,” Jack sighed. His team was learning. Maybe a bit too much.

“Clashed with the interrogator?” Daniel asked.

“He wanted to know too many personal details,” Jack replied. “Sounded like a stalker. I told him that the Etherians don’t like stalkers.” Well, not in so many words.

Daniel chuckled at that, but Carter nodded.

“So!” Jack said, trying some of the side dishes and grimacing. They must have let the Marines help out in the kitchen today. “Let’s hope that the head spooks are more reasonable than their underlings.”

“Since we haven’t burnt any bridges so far, I think that’s a safe assumption,” Daniel said.

“The Etherians are meeting with the Germans today,” Carter commented. “They just passed the new legislation in a special session.”

And America was still trying to make half their politicians understand that the times had changed. Jack sighed. Beaten to the goal by the Germans? That was almost insulting. No wonder the spooks were getting pushy - they must be under a lot of pressure.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, September 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...Bundeskanzler ist in Genf eingetroffen, wo er mit den Etherianern Gespräche über eine Allianz führen wird. Nach der Sondersitzung des Bundestags wird erwartet…"

"...of the Organisation of African Unity harshly condemned the Etherians, citing a colonialist policy and cultural imperialism on par with the worst atrocities…"

"...Canadian Prime Minister released a statement reaffirming the country's firm stance towards equality before the law regardless of race, faith or sexual identity, although the bill's still being debated…"

"...while the European Union's plan to release a statement of joint intent has been stalled. Several member states, notably Italy, criticised France and the United Kingdom for their 'hasty policies' and claimed that…"

"...Russian government once more stated that their economic troubles were due to the arrival of the aliens and the effects on the resource market, not on anything else, and…"

"...and the Chinese government released a strongly worded statement warning the Taiwanese government not to approach the Etherians…"

"...of South Korea stated that the country would have to follow Japan's example if it wanted to remain competitive in a world rapidly adapting to alien technology and societies. Asked about the repercussions on their relationship with North Korea, he claimed that…"

"...and the Pope is still in reclusion. Numerous prominent representatives of the Catholic Church have been vocal in their demands that…"

"...Swedish Riksdag passed a law granting equal rights to gay people, although it's as of yet unclear whether the government will enter negotiations about an alliance with the Etherians. Several politicians claimed that the country's long tradition of neutrality was an obstacle to such a course of action, although others cited the fact that the entire Earth was under attack as sufficient reason to seek allies. Pacifist organisations denounced such arguments as…"

"...and after a long and spirited debate with the pastor of my church, I have come to realise that Jesus's love is unconditional and for everyone regardless of their sexual orientation. Therefore, I cannot, in good conscience, oppose the proposed constitutional amendment any longer and will…"

Adora switched off the television before Catra could switch channels again. "I think you're becoming a little too… fixated on this." What was the term? News junkie?

Catra snorted. "I'm just keeping up with the news."

"By zapping through all channels?"

"Yes!" Catra grinned. "It's not as if I need to watch for long before I know what they'll say."

Adora frowned. She still had some issues understanding Earth people. "And what did they say?"

"Some countries want to get our technology and will pass any law they think will make us like them but don't want to look as greedy as they are, and others think we're the devil and want us dead." Catra shrugged. "Same as yesterday:"

"But that politician at the end wasn't like usual!" Adora protested.

"He suddenly found out that his god loves everyone?" Catra scoffed. "You believe that? He was either bribed or blackmailed, I bet."

“He sounded sincere.”

“As sincere as Shadow Weaver,” Catra shot back with a sneer. Adora raised her eyebrows, and she sighed. “Sorry, but I don’t buy this ‘our god suddenly loves you too, and it has nothing to do with the fact you have something we want’ story.” She grinned. “Not without their god saying anything about it in person.”

Adora frowned at her lover. She knew what Catra meant.

“I bet you’d make a much better goddess…”

“Don’t you start! I’m no goddess!” Adora hissed. Priest was bad enough. And the people on Earth would really hate her if they thought she claimed to be a goddess. Or, worse, they might revere her!

Catra giggled. “Just yanking your chain.” She grinned. “And speaking of… we really need to buy you that outfit.”

Adora blushed.

“Are you at it again?” Glimmer scowled at them from where she was reading what data Entrapta had collected on the Bundeskanzler. It wasn’t much - Adora had read it twice already.

“Just passing the time. Why, do you want one as well?” Catra’s grin widened.

“I want you to focus on our meeting with the German ruler!”

“What’s there to focus on?” Catra shrugged. “It’s going to be the same as with the French and British: They want our technology, and we want their soldiers.”

“They have vastly different cultures,” Glimmer retorted. “We can’t just treat everyone the same.”

“When it comes down to it, they all want the same,” Catra shot back.

“Yes, but how they want to get it differs,” Glimmer pointed out. “The Germans don’t have a princess or king, but they didn’t kill their monarchs, either. That makes them different from the French and British.”

“Didn’t the grandson of their last ruler propose to restore the monarchy in Germany for better relations with us?” Adora asked.

“Great-grandson,” Glimmer corrected her. “And that wasn’t received well. Not at all.”

“They didn’t do anything to him, though,” Catra pointed out.

“Anyway,” Glimmer said, “we can’t just half-ass this. Germany is the most powerful economy in Europe, and their industry is very modern. If we can get an alliance with them, then, with the French and British on board, we’re set for the time being.” She looked at Catra. “So, don’t needle them.”

“Sure, sure. They don’t have a sense of humour anyway, according to what I’ve read.”

“That might be British propaganda,” Bow pointed out.

“Well, we’ll find out.”

“No. We won’t find out if they have a sense of humour or not. Not in the middle of our negotiations!”

“Spoilsport.”

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 20th, 1998

“So, the Goa’uld prisoners have refused to use the keyboard so far?”

Samantha Carter nodded. “Yes. We have installed keyboards in both cells, but other than trying out the keys, they have not attempted to communicate with us,” she told Entrapta.

Entrapta frowned and stopped looking around in Sam’s lab, presumably for new things. “Are you sure that they can read without a host? They could be relying on a host for higher cognitive feats and only act on instincts until they can get a host. They do access their hosts’ memories, after all, don’t they?”

“Our intel indicates that this isn’t the case,” Sam replied.

“But did you check?” Hordak asked.

Sam looked at the clone. “If that was the case, then the Goa’uld controlling the animals we encountered should have been more limited in its actions.”

“That might have been instinct as well. Or the creatures were more intelligent than you assumed.”

That was theoretically possible, but Sam doubted it. “With their genetic memory, and based on previous encounters, it seems implausible that they do not retain their intellect outside a host.”

“Well, the small size of their brains means that they have a much more efficient neural structure than humans if they also retain their intelligence,” Entrapta said.

“They don’t piggyback on human brains.” Sam pressed her lips together for a moment, suppressing a shudder at the memories of her own time as a host. “My intellectual capacity wasn’t diminished at all while I was puppeted.”

“Oh.” Entrapta blinked, then bit her lower lip. “I see. But why wouldn’t they communicate with us?”

“We don’t know. It might be their version of only giving name, rank and serial number,” Sam speculated.

“Or they want to force you to provide them with a host to interrogate them, giving them leverage through a hostage - or at least more options to escape,” Hordak suggested.

“That has been mentioned as well,” Sam admitted. And some of the agents had suggested actually doing it.

“So, they’re just being stubborn?” Entrapta frowned.

“Or desperate,” Sam said.

“Well, we wouldn’t kill them,” Entrapta said. “And they could have a more comfortable stay if they cooperated - we don’t know too much about their needs outside a host.”

Executing the Goa’uld prisoners - or one of them, to ‘encourage’ the other - had been suggested as well. Sam understood the Colonel’s attitude towards ‘spooks’ a bit better now. “They haven’t reacted to such offers either.” That was amongst the basics of interrogation. “And yes,” she added when Hordak opened his mouth, “we also made the offer using hieroglyphs they would be able to read.” One of the Goa’uld had been living in the United States for decades, but the other wouldn’t be able to understand or read modern languages.

“I wasn’t going to mention that since it was obvious,” Hordak said. “Did you remove privileges from the prisoners in response to their refusal to communicate?”

“You mean like… torturing them?” Sam asked.

Hordak tilted his head. “Making their cells less comfortable would probably qualify, yes.”

“Hordak! We don’t torture prisoners!” Entrapta scolded him.

He seemed unfazed. “But the people on Earth do.”

“Not in America. We don’t torture prisoners,” Sam said. “It’s illegal.”

“Your history disagrees with that statement,” Hordak said.

“Those were crimes. We won’t torture our prisoners.” Sam shook her head. “That’s ingrained into our laws. Anyone who does torture a prisoner will be persecuted by the law.” If they caught them - Sam had no doubt that the NID would torture people if they thought it would help their goals.

“If removing amenities is not acceptable, and they do not react to offers of better conditions, then you have few options left to entice them into cooperating with you,” Hordak said.

“We’re aware of that.”

“Appeal to their curiosity?” Entrapta suggested. “Show them something they didn’t know before? Offer them to do science? It worked on me!” she added with a smile, then frowned. “Of course, Catra later said it was a dirty trick, but I don’t know if she was serious.”

“Letting them do science would imply giving them a host,” Sam said.

“Not if we make tiny tools for them!” Entrapta smiled.

“I do not think that giving the prisoners access to tools is a good idea,” Hordak said.

“And I don’t think they’re interested in science,” Sam added. But they might be interested in information about Etherians. Seth would have known about their arrival, but Osiris wouldn’t have known about it. It was a decent enough idea. “But I’ll pass it on.”

“Pass it on?” Entrapta tilted her head to the side.

“I am not in charge of the prisoners,” Sam explained. “I can make suggestions, but no decisions.” And she could speak out against questionable ideas such as trying to play one of the Goa’uld against the other based on their supposed animosity.

“Right.” Entrapta nodded. “So… what do we do now? Did you work on a lightsaber yet?”

Sam suppressed a chuckle - this was the first time she had entered her lab since last night. “I haven't had the time yet.”

“So, let’s see what we can come up with!” Entrapta nodded several times and then looked at Sam’s desk. “We might need more space, though.”

“And a safe way to test prototypes,” Hordak added. “Plasma blades tend to be dangerous when they lose containment.”

“Yes.” Sam had been told that all research with the Etherians would be supported by Stargate Command - and the government still desperate for closer ties to the Etherians - but she wasn’t sure General Hammond expected them to research lightsabers. Then again, she had her orders, so asking for a lab to test their prototypes would just be doing her duty…

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, September 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“Yes, small to medium companies are the backbone of our industry. They aren’t famous like our car companies or our arms industry, but they provide the bigger corporations with parts and fill crucial niches in the global economy. So, any agreement about sharing advanced technology will have to keep this in mind.”

Catra felt as if her face had frozen in a polite smile as the Chancellor of Germany - the Bundeskanzler - once again went on about Germany’s industry. They were here to finalise a military alliance, not a trade agreement. But there were more representatives of businesses with him than military officers. At least it felt that way to her.

“Yes, but you also have to consider the need to keep advanced technology safe from spies,” Adora told the man. “Sharing this

technology with every little company is too dangerous."

"I trust our companies," the man said with a slight frown. "They have experience with guarding their technological edge against their competition."

"And against spies?" Catra leaned forward and matched the man's frown. "Not just your other k-countries, but what about alien spies?" She had almost said 'kingdoms' - she blamed her boredom. That would've made the Germans think she wasn't aware of how things were done on Earth and thought they had a king. Or Emperor.

"Well, there shouldn't be any alien spies - you checked, didn't you?" one of the people in suits said.

"We did. But there are more alien species than the Goa'uld," Glimmer said. "You can't just trust we'll catch every spy. And your other countries won't show up - and they want this technology."

"You might have to adjust how you do things - or implement better security for your smaller companies," Bow added.

"That would be possible, but troops used for that would be missing on the front," one of the officers retorted.

"I don't think we want to station soldiers in factories," a man in a suit said with a frown. "The optics would be terrible."

"That might be a good thing," another officer spoke up. "Drive home the fact that we're at war. Some people really don't get that."

"Even the Greens are with us," the first suit said. "We can ignore the fringe."

Adora cleared her throat. "So, speaking of the military, what kind of troops can be mobilised?"

“Well, the Bundeswehr is still in the process of being mobilised for war,” the Minister of Defence said. “We have had some material stowed away, and getting it ready for deployment will take some more time. As will training up the soldiers we need for this.”

“Yes,” Catra said, hissing a little. “Can we get numbers?”

They got numbers. Lots of numbers. But all of them would take a while to be reached. The Germans apparently hadn’t been ready for a war. They had some troops ready but in very limited numbers. Still… “I think we can work with that,” Catra said. “It’ll take time sorting out how we move them and deciding which planets we’ll attack. And we need to coordinate with the rest of the Alliance. Alliances,” she corrected herself - the Princess Alliance had now an alliance with the British and the French and soon with the Germans. That would get confusing.

“Ah, yes.” The Chancellor nodded several times. “And speaking of coordinating, have you considered our proposal for increased trade between Germany, I mean the European Union, and Etheria?”

Catra slowly unsheathed her claws under the table and scratched its underside.

“We would have to discuss that with the European Union, and we’re not ready to negotiate any trade agreements,” Glimmer told him. “We’re talking about a military alliance. Trade can be discussed at a later date.”

“Yes,” Catra nodded emphatically. Her tail was twitching again, but she managed not to flatten her ears.

“Alright!” The Chancellor smiled. “We’ve had proposals to convert submarine yards to spaceship yards. Would that be feasible?”

If not for Adora’s hand on her thigh, Catra would have hissed.

“Such technical details would be best discussed with our experts,” Bow said. “We would have to know more about your ‘submarines’

as well.”

One of the aides started pulling sheets out of a suitcase.

“We should’ve taken Entrapta with us,” Catra whispered as Bow studied the first sheets.

“Yes,” Adora agreed. “She would love this.”

She would also have to be supervised so she didn’t give out technological secrets for free, but yes, this was a matter best aimed at Entrapta. Bow was a techmaster, but he wasn’t experienced with mass production. Or factories - except for knowing how to sabotage them.

Which was tempting, Catra thought with a grin.

“Catra, no!” Adora whispered.

“So,” Glimmer spoke up, probably to cover for Adora’s scolding, “we should have sorted out all the important points, then.”

Like an hour ago, in Catra’s opinion.

“Well, the military parts, yes,” the Chancellor agreed.

“Good. I think we need to discuss the rest at a later date.” Glimmer nodded. “It’s getting late.”

“It’s late afternoon.”

“Orbit lag,” Glimmer lied.

“Ah, of course! So… same time tomorrow?”

Catra didn’t whimper. She had survived worse.

But she wanted to.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 21st, 1998

"...and the Chancellor and the Etherians have been meeting with several representatives of the German arms industry, likely discussing technology transfers, although no details were forthcoming and the government declined to comment on…"

"Figures that the Germans are at the forefront when it comes to getting new technology," Jack O'Neill commented as he shut off the television in the meeting room. "Greedy bastards." He noticed that Daniel was frowning at him. And Carter had that perfectly polite expression on her face that meant she was annoyed at him. "I'm just letting off some steam. No need to mention Operation Paperclip." He grinned when Daniel closed his mouth and pouted.

"I doubt that the Etherians will show such preference to the Germans," Teal'c said. "That would vex the British and the French for no discernable reason."

"They haven't said that there is a deal, just that they're talking about one. It's probably just propaganda for the German public," Jack agreed. "They've got an election coming up."

Daniel frowned again. "You're following German politics?"

Jack snorted in return. "If it's relevant." And it helped when dealing with stupid politicians wanting advice. He was an officer, not a consultant!

"Ah."

"Entrapta didn't mention anything about that," Carter said.

"She might have forgotten about it," Daniel speculated. "You were pretty busy."

Carter didn't blush, but she tensed for a moment. "We were discussing how best to interrogate the Goa'uld."

Jack raised his eyebrows. Entrapta was a sweet girl - woman, he corrected himself; she might act like a teenager, but she was about thirty years old, after all. But she could be very scary when developing new technology. Just thinking about her being interested in interrogation techniques - or tools - was enough to make him feel queasy.

"We didn't discuss torture," Carter said. "Well, Hordak mentioned the possibility, but Entrapta didn't entertain the possibility."

Of course the bastard would have no qualms about torturing people. Or aliens. Jack snorted.

"What did Entrapta suggest?"

"Using their curiosity against them," Carter explained. "But I fear her suggestions would result in a higher risk of escape."

"Ah. On the other hand, our own experts haven't gotten anything out of the Goa'uld so far," Jack said. If not for the Etherians being involved, he was sure they would have attempted torture already. But when your friends were used to locking up prisoners in their palaces' guest rooms, even the worst spooks had to control themselves. They couldn't risk alienating the friendly aliens with more spaceships than the United States had warships.

"The false gods might expect that they will be disposed of once they have no more information to give out," Teal'c said. "A logical assumption."

"We wouldn't murder prisoners!" Daniel protested.

"Of course not," Teal'c agreed. "But given their numerous crimes, the death penalty would be the likely result of a trial."

"I'm sure that our experienced interrogators have mentioned that to our guests," Jack told his friend. "But the Goa'uld probably don't trust them. Not that I'd blame them for it."

Daniel frowned again. He was still a little naive.

But before Jack could point that out to his friend, Hammond entered the room. And his expression told Jack that he didn't have good news.

"SG-1." The general nodded at them. "As of this morning, the Security Council has officially created the International Stargate Command Organisation. The President has agreed to transfer control over the Stargate to the new organisation."

Jack clenched his teeth. He had known this was coming, but it still felt like a punch in the gut. After all their efforts, all the dead, all the money the Air Force had poured into this, the United Nations would now reap the benefits.

Damn.

*****

Spooks Part 2

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 21st, 1998

"So, they won't talk to us?" Adora bent down and peered at the tank in which one of the Goa'uld they had captured was held. It looked like a fish tank to her, but mentioning that would be rude.

"I wouldn't want to talk to you either if you kept me in a fish tank," Catra commented.

"It's not a fish tank," Sam protested. "It's a secure habitat for alien life forms."

"That's sciency for 'fish tank'," Catra retorted with a grin.

Adora sighed. "And they can understand us in this form?"

"Yes." Teal'c nodded.

"Their senses cover the same range as humans - mostly. There are a few differences, but whatever sound a human can make, Goa'uld can hear," Entrapta explained.

"But Osiris is unlikely to understand anything except for Old Egyptian," Daniel added. "He was sealed in a stasis jar for thousands of years. Seth, though, should understand us perfectly fine."

"Ah." Right, the Goa'uld could just access their host's brains to learn everything they knew. Adora suppressed a shudder - Seth had tried to possess her.

"And Daniel and Teal'c talked to them in their language, but the snakes didn't want to talk back, either." Jack shook his head. "That's the longest temper tantrum I've ever seen."

“Aren’t they just doing what you said prisoners had to do? Refuse to give the enemy any information other than name, rank and serial number?” Adora asked.

Jack frowned at her as if she had something mean, but Daniel chuckled, and even Sam smiled. “It’s not the same.” Adora wanted to ask why it wasn’t the same, but he went on: “So, Entrapta and Carter built some keyboards for them, and specially made screens that they can see through the windows of their cells. Yet they still refuse to communicate.”

“We tested the keyboards - they work perfectly fine. And we demonstrated them to the prisoners. Although Seth should already be familiar with keyboards since he was captured in the United States,” Entrapta said. “They just don’t want to talk to us.”

Adora wrinkled her nose. Perhaps they should respect that? They weren’t the Goa’uld - they respected the rights of their prisoners. Or should - she wasn’t sure that the cells here were actually nice enough for that. The Goa’uld had no privacy at all. Still…

“Make them eat rations and tell them they can order better food?” Catra suggested. “They’d have to talk to us then.”

“We’re not going to torture them,” Entrapta protested.

“The Horde lived on ration bars,” Catra retorted.

“And that wasn’t alright!” Glimmer cut in with a grimace. “That was torture!”

“The grey ones were OK,” Adora said. “Way better than the brown ones.”

Everyone looked at her as if she had said something stupid. She frowned at them, but Glimmer just shook her head, and Catra giggled.

“I am now really curious whether or not those ration bars are worse than MREs,” Jack said.

“Well, we don’t have any of them with us, so we can’t compare them,” Bow said. “But Horde ration bars were really horrible.”

“Disgusting.” Glimmer nodded with a shudder.

Adora looked at Etnrapta and Hordak.

“They provided the troops with a perfectly balanced meal,” Hordak said.

“And if you used food additives, they were quite palatable,” Entrapta said.

“‘Food additives’?” Adora asked.

“Seasoning,” Catra said. “Force Captains got them.”

“Ah.”

“But we’re not here to talk about torture food,” Glimmer spoke up. “We’re here to make the Goa’uld talk.” She looked at the tank and grinned. “And I think Entrapta’s plan has a good chance of working.”

“Making them curious?” Jack asked. “By showing them the news? A tv show that ends on a cliffhanger?”

“No,” Entrapta said. “I’m talking about magic.”

“Magic,” Jack repeated in a flat tone.

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded. “If we had activated Earth’s magic already, I could teleport around. I bet that would make them talk to us.”

“Unless the Goa’uld can use magic as well, then,” Jack pointed out.

“I doubt that they can use magic,” Daniel said. “None of our sources show them using any power that wasn’t based on technology.”

“I think if they had access to magic and then lost it a thousand years ago, they would have searched for the reason for said loss,” Teal’c added. “But I know of no such venture.”

“Well, I could restore magic,” Adora offered. “It wouldn’t take long.”

“There’s something wrong with world-changing actions being done on a whim in five minutes,” Jack muttered.

“Well, we don’t need to activate Earth’s magic for Adora to use magic, right?” Daniel smiled.

“But we might not want to show them her transformation,” Catra was quick to add. “And I don’t think we should hurt someone so Adora can demonstrate her magic healing.”

Adora nodded. Of course not!

“It would be the easiest solution,” Entrapta said. “Activating magic, I mean. Or… I could show them our technology!” She beamed. “I bet they would be curious about our bots.”

“They’ll probably think any magic used is technology anyway,” Jack pointed out, a little belatedly.

“But showing them our technology might also give away important information,” Carter said.

“They already know we’re working with Etherians - even if they don’t know they are Etherians,” Jack told her. “Let’s try technology first before we change the world for a chat with snakes.”

*****

Samantha Carter nodded at the Colonel’s words. Returning magic to Earth just for an interrogation… their superiors wouldn’t accept that. And the Goa’uld knew their own technology. So, it had to be Etherian technology. Or Horde technology. Or… “We might be able to use Ancient technology,“ she suggested.

“First Ones technology? Wouldn’t they know that?” Entrapta asked. “They use the gates, after all.”

“Yes, but they aren’t familiar with the Ancient technology on Etheria,” Sam explained. She looked at Teal’c.

“Indeed. It’s not conforming to Ancient technology known to the Goa’uld,” he confirmed.

“So… First Ones technology.” Entrapta nodded. “We don’t have too much of that here.”

“I can summon my sword. After transforming out of their sight,” Adora said. “And I can make it change shape.”

“It slices, it dices, it makes julienne fries,” the Colonel commented.

Catra snickered, but Adora pouted - and Sam made a note that they might be familiar with the idiom.

“But we still should show our bots,” Entrapta said. “And Hordak’s technology.”

Hordak nodded. “They should be familiar with Horde Prime’s technology, but my own developments, and those of Entrapta, will be unknown to them.” He nodded at Entrapta, who smiled back at him.

They wanted to show off, Sam realised. Well, she could understand the feeling. Perhaps a bit more than she should - but what scientist didn’t like showing off at least a little? Even Daniel wasn’t immune, as his lessons and briefings revealed.

“Let’s start with the bots then,” the Colonel said. “We can save Adora’s Swiss-army-sword-magic for later.”

“Yes!” Entrapta beamed. “I’ll call Emily so she can lead the others inside.”

“The others?” The Colonel asked.

“I brought more bots - they need to get down to Earth anyway. Being cooped up on a ship all the time isn’t healthy!” Entrapta nodded and pushed a button on her multitool. “Emily? Get in here!”

Sam turned to the intercom, but the Colonel was already calling the entrance so the guards would let the bots through.

“Have someone guide them so they don’t get lost,” Entrapta said. Then she blinked. “Uh… can they get in here?”

Sam pointed at the large door in the back. “Yes. There’s a freight elevator there. It would have been impractical to move heavy machinery through the smaller corridors.”

“Isn’t that a security risk?” Catra asked, cocking her head as she looked from the habitats to the elevator.

“We’ve got it under guard,” the Colonel said. “And usually, the habitats aren’t here but in secure cells.”

“In cells?” Adora frowned. “Isolated?”

“First rule of handling prisoners for interrogation is not to let them talk to each other and coordinate their stories,” the Colonel replied.

“But… they are all alone, all day?”

“They can talk to us anytime they choose.”

“That sounds like torture,” Hordak said. “At least some would consider it torture - I can understand, given the intellect of the average soldier, that not having to talk to them could also be a blessing.”

“Hordak!” Glimmer glared at him.

Entrapta, though, slowly nodded. “Yes. Some did claim that isolation is torture. I discovered that when I researched what was

considered torture on Earth."

"Let me guess: You found Amnesty International, right?" the Colonel asked.

"Yes."

"They are sometimes seen as a little controversial," the Colonel told her.

"Mostly in countries that they criticise," Daniel added. "They are also strictly against the death penalty." Sam saw that he didn't look at the Colonel.

Fortunately, Entrapta's bots arrived before this subject could be discussed further - Sam was sure that the Etherians weren't in favour of the death penalty.

"Emily! Come over here! And you too, Gaby! And Silvie!"

Two smaller, but still quite large, bots followed Emily to the group. And the Goa'uld had noticed - Sam saw that both were paying close attention to the bots.

Something she should have done as well, she realised when the bot named 'Gaby' walked to a desk and started scanning the computers there while Silvie was picking up tools on the other side of the room. "Please don't touch anything," Sam said belatedly.

"Put it down, Silvie!" Entrapta said. "You can play with it later. Now you have to show what you can do!"

Emily beeped, and Entrapta shook her head. "No, this isn't an indoor shooting range. Just demonstrate on low power setting."

"Ah… how about not shooting anything on any setting inside the base?" the Colonel said.

Sam couldn't explain how a huge spherical three-legged robot could look sad, but Emily managed. Entrapta patted the bot's dome with her hair. "There, there - we'll get you something to shoot under safe conditions. Safe-ish, at least."

But Silvie and Gaby were already working on something - something the two Goa'uld were very interested in.

Something using First Ones technology, Sam realised. And…

"Are they making a bot?" Daniel asked.

"Yes! A prototype spy bot Mark II!" Entrapta confirmed. "One that can fly!" She frowned. "Well, it will fly once we solve the tiny little issues with making a small engine that won't blow under stress and still is powerful enough to let it explore a star system."

"Or, alternatively, is fast enough to serve as ordnance," Hordak added.

Judging from the beeps from all three bots, they didn't like that idea.

"Hordak!"

Neither did Entrapta.

"I meant for non-sapient bots," the former warlord tried to defend himself.

"They can still learn enough to become sapient!" Entrapta protested. "We can't use them as missiles."

Ah, yes. Artificial intelligence rights - another touchy subject Sam would rather not go into right now.

*****

Catra sighed as Entrapta scolded Hordak about using bots as missiles. Bots weren't people. Sure, some of them were

exceptions, but the vast majority didn't have any more brains than any other machine - she would know; she had had to command tons of the things in the war. They made Kyle look like a genius.

But at least the prisoners were paying attention - she could see the snakes all but pressing their ugly little heads against the fish tanks' glass to study the bots as they built another bot.

Her ears twitched as she overheard O'Neill mutter: "Just what we need - self-replicating bots."

"That possibility always existed once we encountered sufficiently complex and capable robots, Sir," Sam told him. "Although for truly self-replicating bots, they would have to be able to provide the components and the raw materials as well."

"And how likely is that? The brass will want to know if we don't just have to deal with aliens but Skynet as well."

"It shouldn't be too difficult to construct mining bots, Sir."

"Great."

Catra shook her head. It seemed that O'Neill was more worried about what the Etherians could do than about the Goa'uld. Well, it fit him, in her opinion.

But they were here to interrogate the prisoners, not discuss O'Neill's hangups. She kept an eye on the Goa'uld as the two bots, with some concerned beeping from Emily, finished the spy bot.

It didn't look very different from the models she had used in the war. A small bot with a round body like the others and cameras rather than weapons, scurrying around on three legs. Whatever changes Entrapta and Hordak had made must have been internal.

"Oh, look at it go!" Entrapta gushed. "Already used to walking!"

"Shouldn't that be standard?" Daniel asked. "Or do bots have to learn how to walk?"

“That depends on their control matrix,” Entrapta replied. “They can come pre-programmed, like most bots we used in the war - with the networks copied from older bots. Or they can learn from scratch, as you say - that way, they tend to be a bit more effective, although it takes longer for them to be ready for deployment. They can learn more routines that way, though.”

“Ah.” Daniel nodded. “Like people?”

“The control matrixes use networks similar to neural networks,” Sam told him.

The spy bot was demonstrating its sensors and other gear now - First Ones technology, Catra realised; she had seen those scanning rays before. She focused on the Goa’uld’s reaction and could see their tails twitch more and more. Of course, that didn’t have to mean anything - they weren’t like her - but she would bet that it meant they were agitated. Or excited.

“And now, testing the gravity generator!” Entrapta announced.

The spy bot stopped moving, pulled its legs in - and a humming noise filled the room.

Catra clenched her teeth; it didn’t actually hurt her ears, but it grated - though she seemed to be the only one affected. The others probably couldn’t hear it.

And then the spy bot rose into the air and started to float around. Like that droid in the movie. The legs unfolded again, further showing the parallels. The top rotated as well, small cameras looking at everything in the room.

And at the Goa’uld. A red light appeared, a cone moving over the first, then the second Goa’uld.

“Ah, the scanner works as well!” Entrapa beamed. “Look!” She pushed a button on her tool, and floating holograms of the two snakes appeared. “It’s not quite as detailed as our magic scanner, nor with the range that one has, but it’s a medical scan!”

She bent forward, her hair lifting her up, and looked at the Goa'uld. "Hello? Do you want to communicate now?"

"They can't hear us," Sam told her.

"It would be counter-productive if they could listen in on our talks," O'Neill added.

"Oh." Entrapta blinked, then two hair tendrils shot out, grabbed a whiteboard and a marker and started writing.

HELLO! YOU CAN USE THE KEYBOARD!

The first Goa'uld, Osiris, didn't react. Well, they didn't use the keyboard.

The other, though, Seth, started to type, using its tail.

WHO ARE YOU?

Entrapta beamed.

I AM ENTRAPTA, PRINCESS OF DRYL

"We're supposed to get intel from it, not the other way around," O'Neill complained.

"You have to give data to receive data. Even if you're just observing, the act of observation affects the observed, which is kind of giving data," Entrapta told him.

"And he should know our names - we know he saw us on television before we captured him," Catra reminded them.

Seth was typing again.

WHAT ARE YOU?

Entrapta cocked her head, frowning, "I just told you!"

ENTRAPTA, PRINCESS OF DRYL

ARE YOU A TAU'RI?

"Well, now that's a matter of opinion. What do you think, Sam? We are the same species - we can have viable offspring without genetic manipulation - but so were the First Ones. And I don't think he'd call the First Ones Tau'ri."

Before Sam could answer, Entrapta wrote on:

WHAT IS YOUR DEFINITION OF A TAU'RI?

A HOST SPECIES FROM THIS PLANET

NO, I AM NOT FROM THIS PLANET. AND I AM NOT A HOST SPECIES.

O'Neill sighed. "Who thought it was a good idea to let Entrapta start the interrogation?"

And then the other Goa'uld started typing, and symbols Catra didn't know appeared on his screen.

"Oh, he's using hieroglyphs!" Daniel exclaimed in the same tone Entrapta had when she saw tiny food. Or a First One relic.

Catra snickered again as O'Neill groaned.

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"How can the snake type hieroglyphs?" Jack O'Neill asked. It was a dumb question and not relevant, but he wanted to know.

"I've added a database with the hieroglyphs known to us to the tiny keyboard, accessible through the touchpad on the keyboard - or the keyboard, with key combinations," Entrapta explained. "They can use their tail or other limbs to draw on the pad or just flick through the database until they find the symbol they want, although the sorting algorithm was a bit of a guess - I don't know what the Goa'uld would find intuitive, and the Japanese system wasn't applicable since the hieroglyphs are drawn differently, so

sorting according to the number of strokes needed to draw them was not applicable. I wonder what system they use for their own communication."

"They probably dictate to a slave," Jack said. That seemed to fit them.

"That is correct, O'Neill," Teal'c confirmed.

Jack grinned. "So… what's Osiris saying?"

"He's warning us not to trust 'the traitor'," Daniel replied, looking slightly put out.

Jack snorted. That, too, should have been expected from a snake. He glanced at Seth's screen.

I NOTICED THAT I COULD NOT TAKE OVER THE BLONDE WOMAN. SAME SPECIES?

"Someone needs to make him understand that we're the ones asking the questions," Jack said.

Catra made a sort-of agreeing noise.

"Well, should I tell him yes? It's not true, but we're both princesses," Entrapta asked. "And the jury's still out whether or not First Ones are the same species as humans."

"It might keep the Goa'uld from trying to possess us. Or at least you and Glimmer," Bow pointed out.

Jack shook his head. "They'll probably still try it if they have the opportunity - out of desperation or because they suspect a lie." He doubted that the snakes would trust them to tell the truth since the Goa'uld would lie if their positions were switched.

"Ah." Entrapta nodded and typed with her hair.

1. YOU ARE SETH, CORRECT?

YES.

Jack wanted to step in and take over. Entrapta wasn't a trained interrogator. And she was too trusting - or naive. But as long as she listened to the others, there was no reason to be rude to her.

He glanced at Daniel. "What's Osiris saying?"

"Well, technically, he's typing," his friend replied. Jack rolled his eyes, and Daniel cleared his throat. "Sorry. Anyway, he's telling me how Seth betrayed him and Isis, and… well, basically how everything is Seth's fault. And he's asking where Isis is." He grimaced.

Jack shook his head again. "Tell him that she died when her stasis jar was broken centuries ago."

While Daniel started picking through hieroglyphs, Jack looked back at the other Goa'uld. Entrapta was typing again.

YES, WE WERE NEVER RULED BY THE GOA'ULD.

Well, Seth had seen them on TV, Jack reminded himself.

DO YOU TRUST THE TAU'RI?

Jack narrowed his eyes. That was less subtle than he had expected. On the other hand, perhaps Seth thought that the Etherians had taken control of Earth, overtly or covertly.

SOME ARE OUR FRIENDS.

AND THE OTHERS?

"Osiris is asking if he can visit Isis's grave," Daniel said.

Jack didn't have to look at his friend to know that Daniel looked sympathetic. Even though his own wife had been taken from him by the Goa'uld. Or perhaps because of that.

“We did an autopsy on the corpse, Sir,” Carter informed him. Was that a wince?

Jack sighed. “And I guess that all the parts are now floating in formaldehyde in some jars, ready to be studied?” Couldn’t be too many jars, of course, given the alien’s size.

“Yes, Sir.”

“It’s a perfectly valid request, Jack.”

“You… didn’t bury her?” Adora sounded shocked. And no snarky comment from Catra.

Carter pressed her lips together and tensed. Jack held up his hand - he was their commanding officer. This was on him. “We need more information about Goa’uld. We don’t know enough about them, how their bodies work, anything.”

“But you can scan her. Then you have all the data you need. You don’t need to keep the body except for some tissue samples, do you?” Entratpa apparently had stopped chatting with Seth.

Jack sighed. He would have to convince the brass - well, that shouldn’t be too hard, not if the Etherians supported it. “We’ll see about a funeral. Ask Osiris how we should bury her - but tell him no pyramids.”

No one laughed at his joke.

“I doubt that he would expect a pyramid for her,” Daniel said as he typed. “Based on his era, it will likely be a grave chamber in a small temple.”

“That won’t go over better with Congress, I think,” Jack said. The Etherians still looked… disapproving. “Don’t forget that they don’t care about the dead humans,” he reminded them. “Seth didn’t ask about his followers, did he?”

“No. Should I remind him?” Entrapta asked.

Jack shook his head. “Let’s see how long it takes him to remember them.” Probably forever, in Jack’s opinion.

ARE YOU THE NEW PROTECTORS OF THE TAU’RI?

“Uh…” Entrapta looked around, “Kinda?”

“Technically, we are,” Bow said.

“Officially, once we have the Alliances signed,” Glimmer added.

“Tell him that we will protect all the Tau’ri,” Adora said, nodding curtly.

YES

The snake couldn’t hear them - but they could see them. Could gauge their reactions. And they were smart. Seth had thousands of years of experience with manipulating people, Jack reminded himself.

Maybe they should call in spooks. No - those had no experience with Goa’uld. They would try to treat them like humans.

And that would be a disaster. Wait! “‘New protectors’?” He frowned. “Does that mean there were old protectors?

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“Old protectors?” Adora looked at Jack, then at the others.

“I think assuming that there were old protectors solely based on Seth’s question is reaching a little,” Daniel pointed out. “While he certainly knew about the Etherians’ arrival, he might merely be trying to confirm their policy towards Earth.”

“I am not aware of any protectors of Earth - or the Tau’ri as a whole,” Teal’c said. “However, certain planets are off-limits to Goa’uld attacks. I was never told why, though. I assumed it was a decree of Ra, like the order to leave Earth alone. However, the

planet Cimmeria was protected by unknown forces against the Goa'uld."

"Right." Jack nodded. "But Earth doesn't have anything like it. Or the snakes would have been killed long ago."

"Cimmeria could've been protected by another faction of the Goa'uld posing as the Norse gods," Daniel suggested.

"The technology used was unlike and beyond the Goa'uld's known capability," Sam objected.

"It certainly wasn't Ra," Jack said. "He wouldn't have posed as another god that wasn't under his command - or tolerated others posing as such gods."

Adora was a little confused. "Could you explain what happened on Cimmeria?"

"Oh, sorry!" Daniel blushed. "It's a planet with a population that worships the old Norse gods, and when we arrived there, a defence mechanism - Thor's Hammer, it was called - captured Teal'c and Jack and sent them into a labyrinth where they had to fight a former alien host. We managed to disable the mechanism and save them."

"With the help of a native named Kendra," Sam added.

Ah. That explained… not very much.

"Did you recover the technology? Did you analyse it?" Entrapta asked.

"No." Sam shook her head. "But it didn't resemble any known Goa'uld technology. Or Ancient technology."

"So, it wasn't the First Ones," Adora said. "And I don't believe the Horde would have done anything like it."

“They would have conquered the planet, not defended it against the Goa’uld,” Hordak said.

“Do you want me to ask him about Cimmeria?” Entrapta cocked her head.

“If he knows about it, then that changes things,” Daniel said. “The Norse gods weren’t worshipped when Ra was driven from Earth. So, whoever took the people from Earth to Cimmeria did so after Ra had left. If Seth knows about it, he might have had contact with them.”

Jack nodded. “Ask if he knows about Cimmeria.”

DO YOU KNOW A PLANET NAMED CIMMERIA?

NO

That was quick. Of course, that didn’t mean it had to be a lie - Seth would probably be more cautious if he were lying. Still…

“He’s watching us. He knows we’re talking about something, “Jack said. “Damn - could he be able to read lips?”

Read lips? Oh.

“We can’t dismiss the possibility,” Sam said, wincing.

So the Goa’uld might have been able to understand what they were discussing?

“Overestimating an enemy is often as bad as underestimating them,” Hordak pointed out.

“Well, let’s huddle for the next discussion,” Jack said.

“Huddle?” Adora asked.

“Gather round, like this.” He demonstrated. “So… we need to know if he knows anything about Cimmeria’s protectors. Any

suggestions on how to ask that without revealing what we know and don't know?"

"Uh." Adora hadn't been trained in interrogation. That had been something Shadow Weaver had reserved for herself. She probably hadn't wanted to teach Adora how to spot lies either.

"Let's just ask Seth about what he did on Earth. Let him talk and see what we can find out," Catra suggested. "We can ask about Cimmeria later."

"And what about Osiris?" Daniel asked.

"He's been sealed in that jar since Ra's departure," Jack replied. "I doubt he has a lot of actionable intel."

"But as a high-ranking Goa'uld, he has a lot of important knowledge," Teal'c pointed out.

"Right. But it's not urgent either. And since he hasn't been raising and murdering cults on Earth for thousands of years, we might make Seth think that we like Osiris more," Jack said.

"Play them against each other." Catra nodded with a grin.

Adora frowned. That seemed manipulative. On the other hand, they needed information. "Let's let them talk? To us, not to each other," she clarified. "Before we make more plans."

"Good idea."

"And we should visit Cimmeria," Entrapta said. "See if we can get more technology samples. Imagine - a completely new technology!"

That was a good idea. Adora nodded. "And we can check how they are doing."

"And if the defence mechanism has been restored. That would mean that their protectors have kept tabs on them and have

returned," Catra added.

Adora's eyes widened. "If it hasn't been restored, then they've been left defenceless!" And that meant they would have to step in. You couldn't leave a planet at the mercy of the Goa'uld!

"Well, the Goa'uld wouldn't know that the defence mechanism was gone without attempting an invasion - and they have no reason to assume it is gone," Jack said. He looked a little guilty, though.

"You know what they say about assuming anything," Catra retorted.

"We should not underestimate our enemies," Teal'c added.

"Yeah…" Jack grimaced. "I guess we'll have to see if the new management is OK with visiting Cimmeria."

New management? Oh, he must mean the United Nations. Adora nodded. "Why wouldn't they want us to visit Cimmeria?"

Jack shrugged. "Oh, lots of reasons. That they didn't have the idea, that they think it's too dangerous, that they think it's too expensive, that they want to move the Stargate first…"

Adora frowned. Those sounded like very silly reasons. But Glimmer nodded with a wry expression. And Catra snorted.

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WHY DID YOU FORM A CULT?

I HAD TO HIDE FROM RA

Samantha Carter heard the Colonel snort at that. "And that's why he used variations of his own name for every cult."

"To be fair," Daniel pointed out, "he was hiding - he did not seek attention or tried to spread his, ah, faith. In all the past cults that

we could identify, he kept the number of his followers small and hid from the authorities."

"Until the mass suicides."

"Ah, yes."

Sam saw that the Etherians grimaced at that.

"Should I ask why his past followers killed themselves?" Entrapta asked.

"Yeah. Let's see how he tries to justify that." The Colonel grinned.

WHY DID YOUR PAST FOLLOWERS KILL THEMSELVES?

Sam saw the Goa'uld hesitate a moment.

I HAD TO LEAVE THEM AND THEY COULD NOT LIVE WITHOUT ME.

"Good answer - blame the victims." The Colonel snorted again. "Ask him why he had to leave them."

WHY DID YOU HAVE TO LEAVE THEM?

IT WAS BECOMING TOO DANGEROUS. I HAD STAYED TOO LONG. RA WOULD HAVE NOTICED.

Catra scoffed. "Didn't his cults always worship Seth?"

"Or Setesh, or similar names," Daniel said.

"Yep, can't really call that hiding. On the other hand, for a snake used to be worshipped by entire countries, he probably was all humble and stuff," the Colonel commented.

"Are you serious?" Glimmer asked. "Do Goa'uld honestly think like that?"

“The false gods are arrogant to a fault, but it would not do to underestimate them,” Teal’c commented.

“Also, we have to consider that Seth was used to a much more limited world - not a world with computers and the internet,” Daniel said. “What measure he took to avoid notice would have been sufficient in the past, like in the eighteenth century, when his last cult suicided.”

“You still found him.” Bow frowned a little.

“Yes, but that was because vast archives have been scanned and archived electronically,” Daniel explained. “That wouldn’t have been possible just a few years ago.”

“So, what should I ask him next?”

“Ask him why he didn’t tell his followers that he’d return.”

Entrapta typed, and, once more, the Goa’uld hesitated just a moment too long to give an honest answer, in Sam’s impression.

THAT WOULD HAVE BEEN CRUEL AND A LIE

“Yeah, right.”

“He’s the picture of the compassionate god.” Catra snorted again.

Seth was still typing.

YOU RULE YOUR PEOPLE - WOULD YOU LIE TO THEM?

Sam pressed her lips together. This was a blatant attempt to drive a wedge between the Etherians and Earth, aimed at the most obvious difference between their worlds.

Entrapta frowned, and her hair flew over the keyboard.

I WOULD NOT LIE TO THEM AND CLAIM TO BE A GODDESS.

WHAT MAKES A GOD OR GODDESS? POWER? YOU HAVE POWER BEYOND BELIEF OVER THE TAU'RI. YOU CAN HEAL YOUR PEOPLE. FEED THEM. GUIDE THEM.

ANY PRINCESS CAN DO THAT. THAT POWER DOES NOT MAKE YOU A GOD.

WHAT ABOUT MAGIC?

That was a good question, in Sam's opinion.

Apparently, the Colonel shared this view since he said: "Well, if you can heal the sick and the lame, feed the masses and raise the dead, we can start talking about what makes a god."

"No, we can't! I'm not a goddess!" Adora blurted out. "Just tell him that we aren't goddesses."

WE ARE NOT GODDESSES. WE ARE PRINCESSES.

SEMANTICS. YOU RULE BECAUSE YOU ARE THE MOST POWERFUL. BECAUSE YOU ARE THE MOST EXPERIENCED. BECAUSE YOU ARE DIFFERENT.

"Well, technically, he's correct." Catra stretched her arms above her head.

"It's not the same!" Glimmer hissed.

Catra nodded. "Yeah, you don't claim to be a goddess."

"We also don't lie to our people!"

Sam glanced at the Colonel. He was pressing his lips together - he probably had to bite his tongue, literally, to keep from snarking.

"Well, fundamentally, the rule of the princesses is based on the magical power that makes them princesses," Hordak said. "Or that made their ancestors princesses. Any legitimacy by lineage still devolves from power."

“We assume that that was how the royal lines started, but we don’t know,” Bow objected.

“Well, it’s the most likely explanation,” Entrapta said. “If the First Ones had installed the royal families, the research base should have had data on that.”

Sam was inclined to agree. But saying so would have been… undiplomatic. Even the Colonel was aware of that.

“Well, how your ancestors came to power doesn’t matter nearly as much as how you use your power - both magical and governmental,” Daniel said. “The Goa’uld only care about themselves. That is the difference.”

“Yes!” Adora nodded several times. “We don’t rule for ourselves!”

“You don’t rule anything anyway,” Catra added. “Well, unless we count Third Fleet.”

Adora scowled at her. “That doesn’t count! I didn’t ask for them to… follow me!”

Entrapta was typing again.

WE USE OUR POWER FOR OTHERS.

AS DO I - IT IS A POOR RULER WHO NEGLECTS HIS PEOPLE.

“You’re a parasite!” Glimmer spat. “Living by possessing people - and exploiting your slaves!”

“Should I tell him that?” Entrapta asked.

“No.” The Colonel shook his head. “Ask him what he did to Osiris.”

This time, the Goa’uld hesitated even longer, Sam noticed.

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Catra clenched her teeth and suppressed the urge to hiss - again - at the lies Seth was spewing on the screen. If one were to believe him, he was the innocent victim of jealous rivals - Osiris and Isis - his weakness being too caring about his followers while, at the same time, being too successful thanks to his followers 'flourishing' under his gentle guidance.

Fortunately, not even Horde Cadet Adora at her worst would have been naive enough to believe him. Not after the way he ruthlessly ordered his followers to suicidally attack them so he could escape. The additional information Daniel had dug up was just confirming that they were dealing with a monster on par with Shadow Weaver - worse than Shadow Weaver, actually. Catra could easily see Seth acting like Horde Prime, spouting drivel about harmony while murdering everyone who didn't fit in enough. Or brainwashing them, she added with a shudder.

"Wow, we're holding Gandhi's spiritual successor here!" O'Neill exclaimed with a chuckle.

"Gandhi?" Adora asked.

"A famous Indian pacifist," Daniel replied. "He was crucial for India gaining its independence from the British colonial rule and used nonviolent means to protest and oppose oppression. Although some of his views and policies have become controversial lately."

"Daniel, if you explain things like that, people miss the point."

"That could be avoided if you pick a better example, Jack."

"Whatever!" Glimmer blurted out. "The snake's lying through its pointed teeth, and no one's buying it! Enough of that! What's Osiris saying?"

"Uh…" Daniel cleared his throat. "I've been translating his messages, though they mostly deal with Seth's treachery, warnings about not believing any of Seth's claims, and his dead wife."

"And he's presenting himself as the innocent victim of persecution?" O'Neill asked.

"The victim of a backstabbing attempt at treason that framed him and his wife as a traitor in the eyes of Ra," Daniel told him.

"What I said, then."

"But he doesn't try to appear as a benevolent ruler using his power and wisdom to rule and guide the humans for their own good," Daniel objected.

"Probably because he hasn't seen us on television and doesn't know anything about us," Glimmer said, scoffing. "Or he'd probably claim his wife was a princess."

Catra shook her head. Sure, Seth was as subtle as a hovertank if you compared him to Shadow Weaver, but the others were reacting a bit too strongly to Seth's claim that princesses were the same as the Goa'uld.

Especially since, well, he wasn't entirely wrong, as Daniel would say. Princesses ruled because they were princesses, and they were princesses because they had magic powers that they were born with. Dress it up however you wanted, it still came down to power. Netossa and Spinnerella weren't ruling a country, but if they wanted to, they could probably find an area not claimed by any princess and take it over. Catra doubted that too many would care.

And she didn't doubt that a princess could be as bad as the Goa'uld. Maybe even worse, though that would take a lot and probably lead to other princesses banding together to deal with you. There probably had been such bad princesses before. She didn't know any example, but Bow was the historian, or at least the son of two historians, not Catra.

But none of that meant that Catra's friends were bad people. "He's just trying to manipulate you," she said. "As we expected. But

compared to Shadow Weaver, he's bad at it." Mostly because Seth didn't know them, not really.

"He's trying his best," O'Neill added. "But he's still a Goa'uld - I bet he can't really take us mere humans seriously."

"The Goa'uld do not consider anyone their peer, or even just deserving of respect," Teal'c said. "Horde Prime might have come the closest thanks to his power, but they would have destroyed him as soon as they found a way to do so."

"Well, he didn't even bother with pretending. Whatever got in his way was destroyed." Catra shrugged. "Anyway, Seth is just trying to suck up to you because he thinks power's all that matters and that everyone's the same." And she was very familiar with that view.

Adora nodded, but she was still clenching her teeth, Catra could tell. And Glimmer was still staring at the Goa'uld as if she wanted to smash them in their cells.

Well, so was Hordak, she noticed. Entrapa looked upset, which must have set this off.

What a mess. In hindsight, they should have left this to Stargate Command. On the other hand, Seth had only started talking once he had seen Adora and the others.

Catra stretched again, the claws in her feet slightly digging into the floor - it was only concrete, so Catra didn't have to worry about damaging a mosaic or some polished wood or expensive carpet. "So, do we have to keep listening to those lies? Or can we do something more productive now? Like taking a nap?"

"Both Seth and Osiris were present when Ra ruled the Earth - and Seth lived through almost our entire written history!" Daniel said with a pout. "The knowledge they hold could change history and offer crucial insight into Goa'uld society."

Catra chuckled. “Well, looks like you just volunteered to keep talking to them.” She tugged at Adora’s arm. “Come on! Let’s get something to eat; I’m hungry!”

Adora didn’t object to being dragged out of the room. That meant she was still mulling over Seth’s words. Probably questioning if she was a Goa’uld-style ruler.

Damn. Catra really wanted to shred the snake with her claws.

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Doubts

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 21st, 1998

"A funeral for the Goa'uld?" General Hammond sounded surprised.

Jack O'Neill, standing at parade rest in the general's office, nodded. "Yes, Sir. Osiris asked to see the body of his wife - or her grave."

The general sighed. "And it happened in the presence of the Etherians."

"Yes, Sir."

"And letting him see the body would be…" The general grimaced.

Jack nodded again and refrained from commenting that getting the body back together would mean solving a puzzle and draining gallons of formaldehyde.

General Hammond sighed again. "And just when we're about to be formally transferred under UN control."

"Yes, Sir."

The general narrowed his eyes at him.

Oops. Maybe Jack had overdone the dutiful by-the-book officer act. "Do you think that the Security Council won't be willing to please the Etherians? It's our mistake, after all." The Russians and the Chinese would love to rub the United States' face in. And the British and the French wouldn't exactly do their utmost to help out, either.

"I think the Security Council's representatives might see this as a way to present themselves as not prone to making the same mistakes we did," General Hammond replied.

Oh, yes. Jack could see that. Damn vultures. And yet… "Speaking of mistakes, Sir…"

Hammond stopped sighing and looking at the ceiling and zeroed in on Jack once more. "Yes, Colonel?"

"Cimmeria was brought up during the interrogation," Jack said.

"The planet with the people worshipping Thor."

"Yes, Sir. The Etherians would like to visit." Jack straightened just a bit. "They are curious about the technology on the planet - and they voiced their concern that our actions might have left the planet defenceless against the Goa'uld."

"How would the Goa'uld find out?" Hammond asked.

"I said the same, Sir. But the Etherians want to go. There was also talk about installing a surveillance drone to keep an eye on the planet." Jack inclined his head. "Captain Carter seemed to think the proposed design was feasible." Feasible enough to have her spend time in her lab with Entrapta and Hordak working on a bot.

"I see. Well, that's another request I'll have to present our new command crew with."

"Yes, Sir." Another glare. Jack didn't show any reaction. "And, speaking of that, Sir: When will the new brass arrive?"

"I just received the news. They will arrive tomorrow."

It was Jack's turn to be surprised. "That's faster than I expected."

"Even the United Nations can move quickly if they're motivated enough." Hammond snorted. "The security up top is working around the clock to ensure that the new United Nations Stargate Command can be kept from accidentally entering the other areas of the base."

‘Accidentally’. Jack snorted - as if the Russians and the Chinese wouldn’t try to use this to spy on the Air Force! “Any word of who’s going to play overlord?”

“We’ll have a joint command overseeing UNSGC operations, with members drawn from all permanent members of the Security Council,” Hammond replied.

A committee! Wonderful!

“They’ll also provide troops and officers to Stargate Command, although, to my knowledge, it’s understood that they will need to be trained before they can cover crucial posts.”

Even better - they’d have to train FNGs to take over. And spooks masquerading as FNGs. “It feels as if we’re expected to train up our own replacements, Sir.”

And Hammond nodded. “That’s probably correct, Colonel. International politics being as they are, we cannot expect Stargate Command to remain heavily dominated by the Air Force.”

“We’re the most experienced, Sir,” Jack spat.

“Which means it’ll take some time until we’re replaced. And the United States will keep troops in Stargate Command. But I think the bulk of our current roster will be transferred to whatever our space forces will end up called.”

“Including my team.” He clenched his teeth. It was a logical development. It made sense. It still grated. He had been with Stargate Command, well, not from the start, but pretty much from the first time the gate had been used.

“Yes.” Hammond smiled. “Your close relationship with the Etherians makes this a no-brainer. The United States need you working with the Etherians fighting a war, not guarding the Stargate.”

“Someone has to keep an eye on this new… command, Sir.” Who knew what the Russians and the Chinese would try to pull if they were left unsupervised.

“I am certain that this concern will be addressed by our superiors.”

“Does that mean we’ll get new troops from the NID?” Jack tilted his head and raised his eyebrows.

Unfortunately, Hammond didn’t laugh. “I was assured that we’d be receiving people with the necessary training to ensure that the Stargate won’t be used in ways that would endanger Earth.”

More spooks. Great. Well, at least that meant leaving Stargate Command would be easier for everyone in SG-1 - Jack knew none of his team members wanted to work with the NID. “Can I tell the rest of my team that?”

Hammond smiled. “Never give an order you know won’t be obeyed, Colonel.”

Jack grinned in return.

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“Team huddle!” Jack O’Neill said, peering into Carter’s lab. As expected, his entire team was there - Carter was going over the data Entrapta had left, Daniel was going over the transcripts from this afternoon, and Teal’c was… thinking, probably.

“Sir?” Carter tilted her head with a very polite expression - she wasn’t in the mood for banter, then.

“Metaphorically,” he told her as he closed the door. “With the snakes back in their cells, we don’t have to fear being overheard. So!” He clapped his hands. “I’ve got good news and bad news. Which do you want to hear first?”

Carter raised her eyebrows, but Daniel seemed to ponder the question. "Uh… bad first?"

"Stargate Command will be formally transferred under control of the United Nations Security Council," Jack said. "The new brass arrive tomorrow."

Daniel blinked, obviously surprised, while Carter pressed her lips together. Teal'c nodded slowly.

"More bad news: It'll be a joint command, committee-style."

"How is that supposed to work?" Daniel asked.

"I assume that they'll have lots of discussions and votes." And Hammond would be forced to make urgent decisions on the spot, which probably would result in him getting the boot - the brass didn't like officers who kept showing them up.

"So, what's the good news?" Daniel asked.

"I haven't finished with the bad news yet," Jack told him with a toothy grin. "We'll have to train up our replacements, and sooner or later, most of Stargate Command - our current command - will transfer to whatever will be our new Space Force." Jack waited a moment, then added: "Including us."

"What?" Daniel gasped.

"They don't want us working for the United Nations," Carter said, looking… not pleased. "Not when we're friends with the Etherians."

"Exactly. And, well - the Space Force will be where the action's at." Jack grinned. "That's the good news. We won't have to suffer the new regime for more than a few months, and we won't end up glorified bodyguards for diplomats." Or casualties of international powerplays.

“We can’t really train up competent replacements in a few months,” Daniel protested.

Jack shrugged. “Not everyone will leave. Hammond might stay if the United Nations don’t piss him off too much. But we’re needed in the war.”

“The Stargate is crucial for the war,” Daniel said.

“Yeah, and I assume we’ll be using it when we can.” Jack grinned. “But we won’t have to deal with that Chinese-Russian clusterfuck. We’ll be kicking snake ass.”

Carter nodded. “We’ll be working very closely with the Etherians, I assume.”

“Yep. I can’t see anyone, not even Kinsey, being as stupid as to assign us elsewhere.” It wouldn’t make any sense.

“I am looking forward to fighting the Goa’uld at the Etherians’ side,” Teal’c commented.

“But… I’m a civilian,” Daniel pointed out. “Will that work for the Space Force?”

His friend didn’t want to become a soldier, Jack knew that. And Daniel wouldn’t be a good soldier anyway. “Of course it will,” he said. “The brass needs you.”

“They can keep me in the office, translating things. If we’re invading planets…” Daniel trailed off.

Jack shook his head. Carter looked concerned as well. “Don’t worry about that,” he told them. “Remember what the Etherians told us about their war against the Horde?”

“Yes…?” Daniel looked confused, but Carter nodded. “The princesses are planning to fight at the frontlines. And in special operations.”

Jack smiled at her. "Exactly. And that means if we want to work with them, we need to send people who can work with them, not just for them. If the brass sends a bunch of marines to work with the Etherians, they'll end up being grunts doing the shooting while the Etherians make the calls." And the United States didn't like subordinating their troops to others like that. "They'll need us. SG-1."

Daniel nodded as well. "Right. The princesses and their friends are like us - not just soldiers, but scientists as well." He smiled. Then he frowned. "But there's no Space Force yet. I mean, not the kind we talked about."

"Give them time," Jack told him. "There's no alliance with the Etherians yet, either. I assume that once we have an alliance, we'll be amongst the first to be transferred out of United Nations Stargate Command." The sooner, the better - he still didn't trust that damn Russian 'scientist'. And yet… "And the last piece of somewhat bad news: We'll have to clear any mission to Cimmeria with our new overlords."

Daniel's face fell again.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 22nd, 1998

She wasn't like the Goa'uld. She didn't claim to be a goddess - quite the contrary. She didn't rule thanks to her powers - she didn't rule, period. She didn't enslave anyone, either. Nor did she lie.

Adora stared at the ceiling above her bed and sighed. No matter how often she told herself that, she couldn't help wondering if it was true. Or, should it be true, if it was enough of a difference. She had led people in the war because she was She-Ra, Princess of Power. Sure, she had the officer training from the Horde, but she hadn't earned her position. Not when she had gotten it, at

least. She had proven herself afterwards. At least she liked to think so.

“Stop moping!” Catra reached over and flicked her nose.

“Ow!” Adora rubbed her nose and pouted at her lover. “I wasn’t moping!”

“You were. Stop thinking about it. Seth is a liar. You’re not a Goa’uld.” Catra shifted and slid from Adora’s side on top of her chest, looking down at her.

“I know!”

Catra raised her eyebrows, and her ears twitched.

Adora deflated. “I just… I wonder if I’ve… What if I weren’t She-Ra?”

“Then you’d have stayed in the Horde, and we would have conquered Etheria together,” Catra told her.

Adora blinked. That was… well, not implausible. Probably even probable. Glimmer was great, as was Bow, and Adora certainly hadn’t saved the Alliance by herself, but… the Princesses Alliance had only started winning the war after She-ra had joined them.

“Which would have been a bad thing, of course,” Catra added. She wasn’t grinning, but she wasn’t entirely serious, either - Adora could tell. Her lover might find the thought funny; Catra had changed, mellowed out, as Bow called it, but her sense of humour was still… sharp and dark or something.

“Yes. But… I’ve been thinking…” Adora started to explain.

“Aha! I knew it!”

“...and I was wondering if we - the princesses - are different enough compared to the Goa’uld.”

“You don’t burrow into people to take over their bodies,” Catra said.

“Not that. The whole… ruling thing. And I know that I’m not a ruling princess,” Adora added with a frown before Catra could say anything. “It’s the principle of the thing.”

“The democracy versus monarchy thing?” Catra cocked her head.

“Yes. Kind of.”

“That didn’t bother you when Daniel explained things,” Catra pointed out.

“Yes.” Adora sighed. “But it wasn’t… It was just a theory back then. And when we arrived at Earth and found out how much was… weird and bad and wrong here…” She shook her head. It had been so obvious that democracies weren’t any better than kingdoms - arguably worse, actually.

“And now you suddenly realised how much worse the Goa’uld are? We already knew that.”

“It’s not that,” Adora protested. “I’m just wondering… without the body-snatching, and the genetic memory, and the eating your kids, what’s the difference between a bad princess and a Goa’uld?”

“Princesses generally look hotter,” Catra said. Her grin quickly faded, though, when Adora frowned at her. “Well…” She shrugged. “Probably not much of a difference. In principle.”

Adora had hoped for a better answer. “So… we aren’t really different.”

“Sure you are!” Catra snapped. “You, Sparkles, Entrapta, Perfuma, Scorpia, even Frosta and Mermista - you’re good rulers. You aren’t like the Goa’uld. You care.”

“Yes.” Adora couldn’t deny that. “But that’s us. What about… other princesses? Future ones, I mean.”

“Ah. You mean… What if Glimmer and Bow’s kid turns out to be bad?” Catra tilted her head forward.

“Well… I don’t think their child, their potential child, would be bad,” Adora said. She didn’t even know if they wanted children. Glimmer probably felt she had to, as a princess, but…

Catra rolled her eyes. “I mean as a hypothetical example.”

“Yes.” Very hypothetical. She couldn’t imagine a child of her friends being bad - really bad, not just children doing bad stuff bad. “What then?”

“Then I guess we grab them, lock them up and let Perfuma and Scorpia talk to them until they learn their lesson.”

Well, that was a Catra plan, alright. Not a bad plan, but… “And what if they and we aren’t around?”

“You mean, what if we all died before it happens?”

“Yes.” Adora nodded.

“Then someone else has to do it.” Catra sat up, straddling Adora’s belly, and shrugged emphatically, which did interesting things to her chest.

“But what if there’s no one who can ‘take them’?”

“There’ll be a She-Ra around.”

That was right. Still… Adora frowned. “You told me that I didn’t have to do everything.”

“Yes.” Catra grinned. “But that wouldn’t be you. It would be your successor. And they probably won’t have much else to do.”

“And you don’t care about her.”

"I don't know her." Catra shrugged again. "I probably won't be around, anyway, to get to know her."

Adora frowned once more. "I'm not going to let you die before me."

"I'm not going to let you die before me," Catra shot back. With a grin, she added: "Let's agree to die together."

"Yes, let's." Adora blinked. "I mean, no! Let's not die at all!"

Catra giggled, leaned down and planted a kiss on Adora's lips.

Adora returned the kiss, wrapping her arms around her lover.

They didn't talk much afterwards.

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"So!" Adora said, a little too loudly, she realised right afterwards, as she sat down to eat breakfast. "Good morning."

Glimmer and Bow both raised their eyebrows at her, then looked at each other for a moment before turning back to stare at Adora.

"What's wrong?" Glimmer asked.

"What? Nothing!" Adora replied. "It's a nice morning, we'll be signing the Alliance with the French today, and… the television isn't showing another riot," she finished, pointing at the screen Entrapta had installed in Darla's kitchen.

"...and international tension is rising as representatives of several African nations have accused France of preparing to intervene with Etherian support in…"

Adora frowned and grabbed the remote to switch the channel.

"...protest turned violent, and the police used tear gas and water cannons to disperse it before it could reach the designated landing zone of the Etherians, and…"

"...of India stated that they considered the concerns about magic that the Chinese ambassador had raised to be unfounded, and…"

"...called for OPEC to develop strategies to deal with the expected change in technology that the aliens will bring, but several member states were unwilling to…"

"....the riots in Tehran continue, and rumours of the Revolutionary Guards refusing to follow orders of the government are spreading. Whether this could lead to a coup remains in doubt, but…"

"...general strike has paralysed Mexico City…"

"…of Iceland has created a government agency to deal with magic, should it be restored to Earth. Its focus is expected to be on the Huldufólk - hidden people, or 'elves' - which are an important part of Icelandic folklore, and…"

"...the United Nations Security Council will formally take control of the Stargate later today, despite protests from…"

"...and anyone reading the Bible, instead of just parroting bigoted televangelists, knows that the Bible didn't limit marriage to a man and a woman - many biblical characters had multiple wives. Further, the parts of the Bible, namely the Old Testament, that can be interpreted as condemning homosexuality also contain other rules that we do not follow any more. Jesus never said anything against homosexuality, and…"

Well, that at least sounded positive! Adora nodded and tuned the channel out. And tried not to glance at her friends' smirks.

"So, what's got her so worked up?" Glimmer asked Catra.

"Seth's claim that princesses are like Goa'uld," Catra replied between swallowing a 'croissant' in a few hasty bites.

"Really?" Glimmer shook her head. "We're nothing like the Goa'uld!"

Adora pressed her lips together. “I’m just wondering what we would do if a princess turns out like one of them. You know, cruel and power-hungry.”

“Check if it’s Double Trouble trying to create drama again,” Glimmer replied.

That wasn’t the point! Adora frowned again. “What do we do if a princess is a bad ruler? Should She-Ra intervene?”

“You’re She-Ra,” Glimmer replied.

“I mean, what if, in the future, a princess turns bad and none of us is around?” Adora explained while Catra sighed. Loudly.

“Ah.” Bow nodded. “Historically, such situations were solved through war or the threat of war. Neighbouring kingdoms usually banded together to deal with, ah, a rogue kingdom if it became apparent that they would not stop trying to expand.”

“Someone missed the Horde, then,” Catra said.

“We didn’t miss it - but by the time Hordak made his move, he had already managed to entrench himself and raise an army that was too powerful to be easily defeated by the Princess Alliance.” Glimmer scoffed. “But we did win, and now the Scorpion Kingdom has been restored.”

“But what if they aren’t attacking their neighbours? Just, ah, ruling like a Goa’uld?” Adora asked.

Glimmer frowned some more. And Bow blinked. “Internal affairs of a kingdom have usually been left to the ruling princess of a kingdom,” he said.

“Meddling in another kingdom runs the risk of starting a war,” Glimmer added. “Everyone would fear that they would be next. If there are issues, like water rights, that’s what the Princess Prom is for.”

“So, if a princess is cruel to her subjects, that’s a topic to discuss at the Princess Prom?” Adora asked.

“More like gossip, I bet,” Catra said, earning her a frown from Glimmer.

“Princesses are expected to rule wisely and lead by example,” Glimmer said. “No one wants to be shamed in front of their peers.”

“But it’s a loose system - there’s no laws or anything,” Bow added. “It’s a touchy subject.”

“Well, maybe there should be a law,” Adora said.

“It would have to be enforced by starting a war, ultimately,” Glimmer pointed out.

“Or by She-Ra,” Bow said. “But that would be seen as a war as well. Two princesses fighting, and all.”

Adora slowly nodded. Maybe that would be a task for She-Ra - and future She-Ras: Dealing with bad princesses.

Catra raised her eyebrows at her, but Adora didn’t react. She had to think about this. If She-Ra was supposed to deal with bad princesses, then there needed to be rules to determine what was bad.

But who would make the rules?

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 22nd, 1998

Samantha Carter stood at parade rest while General Hammond saluted and formally handed over command of Stargate Command to the United Nations Security Council.

The four foreign generals present - she recognised General Li, General Sidorov and General Haig from their first visit to the Mountain, but the French had sent a new officer, General Petit - saluted in return, then everyone shook hands.

"General Petit…" She heard the Colonel whisper next to her.

"Jack!" Daniel hissed in response.

Sam suppressed a sigh. She just knew that the Colonel would make jokes about 'General Little'. At least the United States picked General Hammond as their representative on the UNSGC Joint Command instead of someone from the Pentagon without any experience with the Stargate.

"Let me introduce my staff," General Hammond went on. "Most of you have already met SG-1."

More handshaking followed. General Petit, despite the stereotypes about French womanisers and the Colonel's grumbling, was completely professional as he addressed Sam. More professional than many Air Force officers, actually. She didn't get a read on Li, Haig seemed to be slightly annoyed to be here and Sidorov…

…was looking at the Stargate more than at the people present.

"Samantha!" Dr Georgovich beamed at her. "Now we finally can work together!"

"Iwan." Sam smiled at the enthusiastic scientist. It was hard not to like someone so passionate about their work - and so congenial. Of course, Dr Georgovich almost certainly was working for the Russian FSB, the successor of the KGB, in some capacity, but Sam didn't think he was an actual trained agent - the man was a scientist through and through, after all.

"Too bad we not yet in new location. Not much room for science here."

“It hasn’t been an issue before,” the Colonel said. “The Mountain’s got perfectly fine facilities.”

“Perfectly fine for American Stargate Command, yes. But now we are United Nations Stargate Command!” Dr Georgovich beamed. “New mission! Less war, more science! And other civilian missions!”

“For a civilian mission, there surely are a lot of new soldiers here,” the Colonel retorted, nodding towards the new generals and their entourage.

“Of course! Galaxy is dangerous, scientists need guards.” Dr Gergovich nodded at him. “Take good care of us, da?”

“For as long as we’re here.” The Colonel’s smile showed many teeth.

Sam cleared her throat. “Well, let’s see how we can fit you and your colleagues into our labs here. We’ve made a preliminary plan, but the roster hasn’t been finalised yet.”

“Da! Need to check if all scientists survived gulag, first, before sending them here.” Dr Grogovich chuckled. “It’s not real gulag, of course. Just top-secret research stations in Siberia. But name is tradition.”

The Colonel chuckled at that - he would; he liked dark humour. Sam politely smiled.

“So, once we move to Canada or Australia, we will have one big science building. And another as a spare. And a testing ground for experiments!”

“Once the United Nations decide on a location,” Sam said.

“It better be Canada,” the Colonel commented. “Can’t move to a land without a decent hockey league.”

“Da! I love NHL! Almost as good as Russian hockey league, now that Russians play in the USA!”

“In any bar, those would be fighting words.”

“But this is no bar.” Dr Georgovich laughed again, then turned to Sam. “So, do aliens work with you here as well? Do they have their own lab space? Will they share?”

Entrapta would, in a heartbeat. “They visit from time to time,” Sam replied. “But they have their own research facilities in space.”

“Oh! I love space. Is it public lab?”

“Invitation only,” The Colonel told him. “And the Etherians are a bit touchy about non-allied visitors.”

“Like Americans, da? You still have no alliance.” Dr Georgovich nodded. “Maybe I talk to them. Entrapta is fine scientist, too. Science does not care about country.”

“But scientists generally do,” the Colonel said.

“Bad scientists care!” Dr Gerogovich retorted. “But we are all one world now! We need to think like that!”

A lovely attitude. Sam wished that would be true. But they couldn’t even get all Americans to agree on what had to be done - or to care more about the whole than themselves. “I think that’s an ideal to strive for.” Daniel would agree - where was he, anyway?

She looked around and saw him talking to a French officer. Quite an attractive woman. Probably a member of the DGSE, Sam thought, then berated herself for being petty. She should know better than to judge people for their appearance.

Even though Daniel would be a prime target for a honey trap, as the Colonel called it. At least in the eyes of those who didn’t know him.

“Da! What was President Lincoln said? ‘House divided cannot stand’? Wise words! Earth has to stand united to face Goa’uld!”

Well, there was nothing anyone could say against that. Even though it looked like the Colonel really wanted to disagree.

Sam probably should talk to him if this persisted. They had to work with the newcomers - at least until they were reassigned to Space Force.

“Let’s head to the lab,” she said. A good distraction would help soothe tempers.

*****

Le Palais de L'Élysée, Paris, Earth, September 22nd, 1998

“Well, that’s an impressive palace for a non-princess,” Catra commented as they stepped on the red carpet leading up the stairs to where the French president waited with his wife.

Glimmer looked around - probably trying to figure out if her own palace was bigger, Catra thought with a grin.

“Catra!” Adora hissed next to her.

“I’m not saying anything,” Catra defended herself. “I just had a funny thought.”

“Don’t have funny thoughts when we’re signing an alliance treaty,” Glimmer said.

Catra would have retorted, but they reached the top of the stairs, and the French president greeted them with a wide smile before introducing his wife.

Catra flashed her teeth, matching the man’s smile. She wasn’t an idiot - she knew this was an important diplomatic occasion. Like the Princess Prom, but hopefully with better security. At least the soldiers - those not just standing around at attention - looked

sharper than Frosta's guards. Well, they had Melog with them; they would spot any trap. Probably.

They posed for the press, shook hands a few times so everyone got the message and then entered the palace to actually sign the treaty. Or not - there was more posing and smiling for the press before Glimmer and the president signed the treaty.

Which then was held up so everyone could smile some more for even more pictures. If Entrapta were here, she'd probably be wondering if this was done so the treaty couldn't be denied since there were too many witnesses.

But Entrapta was running tests of their spy bot with Hordak.

"...and we've prepared a small reception here."

Oh? Finally, a good thing! Catra's smile turned genuine when they entered a large room with a buffet. Her nostrils flared when she smelt fish. Grilled fish.

"Don't drool," Adora commented.

Catra snorted - her lover was as fond of good food as she was. Growing up in the Horde tended to result in that.

They made their way over to the buffet and started filling plates with food. The French president seemed to relax as well - he even pointed out French specialities for them.

Which, Catra had to admit, were delicious. So delicious, she refilled her plate before joining Adora and the others talking to the French president and his ministers and generals.

"...and we should start the technology transfer right away. Changing production to advanced vehicles will take some time, so it's best not delaying that any longer than strictly necessary," one of the generals was saying.

“You need educated engineers first - and scientists,” Glimmer retorted. “You can’t really start producing spaceships without knowing what you’re doing.”

Catra snorted. “Well, you can - but it’ll end up like Kyle doing maintenance on a hovertank.”

Adora giggled, Glimmer groaned, and Bow frowned. As expected. But the French looked lost, so Catra explained: “He was in our cadet squad. Hard-working, but a screw-up.”

“He’s a little clumsy, but he’s very brave,” Adora added with a frown at Catra.

“Anyway, the hovertank broke down in the field. Blocked a whole company from crossing a mountain pass because they didn’t dare to push it over the side,” Catra went on. “I think the Alliance should have awarded him a medal for that. Heroically holding the pass or something.”

“Catra!”

But the French were laughing. “Oh, yes, we had one of those in our company as well when I was a recruit,” one of the generals said. “Almost blew himself up with a grenade.”

“So, it’s true you both were originally enemies of the Princess Alliance?” another general asked.

“Yes,” Adora said, standing a little bit straighter. “But we all joined the Alliance to fight Horde Prime.”

Of course, it had happened at pretty much the last possible moment, in Catra’s case. She nodded anyway.

“Well, a common enemy generally has a unifying effect,” the general commented. “We’ve seen the same with the Goa’uld - after the Americans finally informed us.”

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed with a nod.

Catra was tempted to mention that the Americans had wanted to keep their arrival secret as well, but… she wasn't Double-Trouble. Causing more problems for shit and giggles was stupid. Although the reaction of the French might tell her how much they knew about Stargate Command… No, that was stupid as well. They needed Earth united if only to make dealing with the lot of the people here a little easier.

"I'm still a little surprised that our weapons are deemed effective against aliens with spaceships," the first general said.

"Well, on the ground, they don't have better weapons," Catra told him. "Probably worse, all things considered - although your weapons need more supplies. We haven't faced the Goa'uld, though, so our estimation is based on the experiences the Americans have gained fighting them for years."

"Well, we can match the Americans on the ground," the second general said. "Soldier per soldier, at least."

"Only if you send in the Légion," another general retorted. He had a different uniform.

Everyone laughed again.

"But, more seriously, we need to train our troops for fighting the Goa'uld. We can't just send them into battle without preparing them for this." The first general shook his head. "And we need the resources for that."

The easiest way would be to do joint training with Stargate Command, Catra knew. They had the experience - it'd be like some old sergeants giving lessons and training to cadets. It didn't turn cadets into experienced troops, but it cut down on basic mistakes. At least for most cadets.

On the other hand, sometimes, they taught the wrong lessons. Or just didn't know enough. Like the time the Plumerians suddenly decided to start fighting back thanks to She-Ra. All the past Horde actions had shown that they wouldn't fight back in an organised

manner and would stick to individual resistance. They would have to wing it to some degree.

And such training would be good for their own troops as well - both clones and Alliance troops. Heh, former Horde soldiers might be the best pick for this kind of war, what with having been trained to fight princesses with weird magic powers. Not that the training had been very successful.

"We'll have to ask Entrapta to make some Goa'uld-style training weapons. To simulate the effects," Adora told the generals. "At least for the staff weapons - the zat'nik'tels can be used as they are since they stun and don't kill their targets." She blinked. "Unless you hit a target twice. Maybe those should be simulated as well," she added with a weak smile.

"Joint training," Catra said. "Most of our own troops will gain from that as well."

"Right."

Can help too. Know Goa'uld.

"And Melog will help," Catra added, nodding at her friend. "They have experience with Goa'uld."

A number of the officers stared at Melog as if they had forgotten that they were here. Well, Melog could be very sneaky if they wanted. But… Oh. They had forgotten that Melog wasn't an animal. Even though Adora had introduced them.

At least the president smiled and didn't look surprised. But that raised another point. If even the generals were like this… Catra shook her head. "And your troops also need to train for interacting with other species. Like Melog here. Otherwise, they'll make stupid mistakes. Maybe even fatal ones." If Melog had wanted to harm them with their illusions back when they had met for the first time…

“And magic,” Adora added. “People on Earth have weird views of magic.”

A few of the people around them winced. “It’s a touchy subject for many,” the president said. “Mostly because they don’t know what magic can do.”

“It’s more what magic can’t do,” Adora said. “And we really don’t know what Earth magic will be like - your myths and history are a little confusing.”

A lot, in Catra’s opinion. And so many of them contradicted each other!

“But that might be because you have so many people,” Glimmer added. “You have enough people for almost two hundred planets like Etheria. That could spawn hundreds of magical traditions. And, as far as we can tell, you never had a centre like Mystacore on Etheria, where all the sorcerers gather to study and research.”

And to hide from the war, Catra thought. It was a bit unfair, of course, but the Alliance would have done much better even before She-Ra joined them if they had had sorcerers fighting for them. Had done better back when Micah had been with them. But pointing that out would only set off Glimmer.

“Could we send people to study there?” the president’s wife asked.

“That would be up to Mystacore,” Glimmer replied. “They’re not officially part of the Princess Alliance.”

“Your father and your aunt are, though, and they’re the most powerful sorcerers on Etheria and members of the city’s council,” Catra said. It wouldn’t hurt to remind Earth’s people that Etheria might not be united, but that the Alliance pretty much called the shots for the planet.

She caught Adora flinching and blinked. Why would…? Oh. She had just reminded Adora of the reason that princesses ruled, and

her lover was still worrying that she wasn't any better than the Goa'uld.

Damn.

"Well, it would allow us to study magic without having it returned to Earth," the French president said. "That would likely calm down a lot of people worried about magic."

It would also give them sorcerers trained at the best academy in Etheria - maybe the galaxy. Predictable. But they had misjudged Adora.

Catra's lover shook her head. "That would take years. And Etherian magic might not work the same as Earth magic."

"It would also mean that instead of your native traditions, you would have Etherian traditions," Bow said. "A lot of people want their magic back, not someone else's."

"Yes," Glimmer said. "And there's no reason to wait years before returning magic, anyway. Not when so many people want it returned. India sent another request to restore magic, and the Japanese have stated that this is part of what they want to discuss at our upcoming meeting as well."

That made the French wince, Catra noticed. Well, she had expected that.

"We might have to look into hiring instructors, then - France doesn't have, ah, magical traditions," the president said. "Or if we have, they were lost. Our myths don't tell us how to use magic, only what magic did. And our current research into the matter was inconclusive."

"Well, you'll figure it out," Catra said.

The French didn't seem to take much heart from that, though.

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Aéroport de Paris-Charles-de-Gaulle , Roissy-En-France, Earth, September 22nd, 1998

"Well, the food was good, but the company…" Catra stretched as they entered their ship.

"They weren't that bad," Adora objected.

"They wanted us to hand over everything, technology and magic, right away." Catra scoffed.

"They didn't want magic," her lover objected.

"They want magic, just without everyone getting magic," Glimmer corrected her. "And their 'entrepreneurs' wanting unlimited trade with us as if we didn't know how dangerous that is! I hope the British aren't like that, or tomorrow will be the same, just with worse food."

Catra snorted at that.

*****

The Training Session

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 23rd, 1998

"So, there are our FNGs," Jack O'Neill commented as he looked at the soldiers assembling on the field in front of him. "We've got our work cut out for us, Teal'c." They were the worst kind of FNGs, too - FNGs who didn't understand that they were FNGs. Jack knew the type. Most of the members of Stargate Command - the old Stargate Command - had been like that: recruited from elite units, used to being the best. They took a while to be broken down and rebuilt into useful soldiers.

"They are veterans, as I was told, and merely inexperienced where fighting the Goa'uld is concerned. I foresee no trouble teaching them how to fight the servants of the false gods and the false gods themselves as we did to our comrades in arms before."

"Yep. But those aren't Americans, so they'll be more prickly and difficult." Then again, getting Marines to listen to an Air Force officer when it came to ground combat was a challenge by itself.

"I have no doubt that we will rise to the challenge, O'Neill."

"That's the spirit." Jack grinned and kept grinning as he started walking towards the rough formation that had assembled on the field. The officer in charge of the Brits noticed him first and bellowed, the rest of the limeys quickly coming to attention.

The French and Chinese followed, with the Russians a little behind, but all finished before Jack stepped onto the actual field. Four different formations, all of them assembling on their own, with four different officers reporting for training.

"What a mess," Jack whispered after returning the salutes.

Only Teal'c heard him, and his friend didn't react at all.

Then Jack raised his voice. “Welcome to Stargate Command! I’m Colonel Jack O’Neill, the senior field officer of the unit. This is Teal’c, former First Prime of Apophis. He is a Jaffa.” He nodded at his friend and tried to gauge the men’s reactions. There was some tensing, but nothing serious that he could see.

“We’re going to teach you about the way the Goa’uld and their Jaffa fight. I know you’ve been briefed and seen the news, but there’s nothing as impressive as first-hand experience,” he went on. “For that, we’ve prepared some target dummies.”

Everyone turned their heads to look at the range to the side of the field, where, in the open and behind earthen walls, a dozen dummies had been erected by some grunts. “Line up at the edge!”

A minute later, the soldiers were watching the range - and Teal’c, who had stepped into the centre of the firing line with his staff weapon. It was always better to start with something that drew attention when teaching soldiers, and explosions were a sure way to do that, in Jack’s opinion. He nodded at his friend.

“This is a staff weapon,” Teal’c said, holding the staff up. “It can fire plasma bolts upon command. They explode upon hitting the target, generally burning through standard body armour of Tau’ri and Jaffa alike.”

Jack saw a few of the soldiers whisper to each other - some might not have been aware of the Goa’uld term for humans. One of the Russian female soldiers - or spies; they were far too pretty in Jack’s opinion - seemed to be the resident expert for her group. He made a mental note to look up her file later.

Then Teal’c turned to face the field and aimed at the closest dummy. A moment later, the staff fired, and the dummy exploded, sending rubber bits and ballistic jelly all over the place. Teal’c didn’t stop and fired again and again, blowing up another dummy and blasting off the top of a wall of earth, then decapitated the dummy behind it.

Jack's friend wasn't quite smiling when he turned to face the soldiers, but he was standing in a sort of smug way. Jack could tell.

He grinned himself. "That looks impressive, but the staff has a few drawbacks as well. Aiming is kind of hard since the thing isn't ergonomic. And it has a low rate of fire - relatively low." It easily beat an M79 or an M203, of course. "But one hit, and you're dead even if you're wearing body armour. So, don't get hit." He grinned.

The chuckling amongst the soldiers sounded just a little bit forced; they weren't green soldiers.

"Now, the second common weapon in our enemies' arsenal." Jack drew the zat'nik'tel from his holster. "Looks weird, doesn't it? That's a zat'nik'tel." He demonstrated the safe and active modes. "It's smaller than a staff weapon and works differently. If you get hit with it, you'll be stunned. Hurts like a bitch, too, trust me about this." This time, the chuckling was a little more reluctant. "Then if you get hit a second time, even if it's minutes apart, you die. Just like that. Dead as a doornail, leaving an intact corpse."

No one was chuckling now.

"And if you get hit there times in succession…" Jack turned and fired at the closest standing dummy. The first and second shots didn't do anything. The third disintegrated it. "...you're literally gone."

Everyone was staring now. It really was like teaching Marines.

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The FNGs were good. Better than the average SGC recruit, Jack O'Neill had to admit. Of course, the other countries would send their best for this assignment - if only so they could build up a cadre to train more troops back home once they had experience fighting the Goa'uld.

He watched a squad of British soldiers navigate the simulation field, trying to get close to Teal'c. Fire and move, the simulated shots not quite as loud as the real thing. Jack didn't see any obvious mistake - but they had never fought Jaffa. And they had no idea how fast Teal'c could run. One more leap… yes.

Teal'c dashed out from under cover, staff weapon firing - at the ground in front of the closest soldiers, throwing up dirt and smoke, temporarily blinding the limeys. Not for long - they changed positions as soon as they realised what had happened - but they reacted as if they were fighting humans.

Teal'c closed the distance far quicker than they expected - he jumped over the rock the first two were hiding behind before the dust cloud had settled. Two jabs, not even shooting, and both men's simulation gear marked them dead.

The rest of the squad started firing, but Teal'c jumped to the side, behind another rock, then returned fire. Simulated fire. One soldier was caught in the open and went down, and Teal'c used two more real blasts to throw up more dust clouds.

The limeys fell back, expecting another charge - and ended up flanked by Teal'c, who had sprinted to the side even faster than they had expected. And that was it for this exercise.

"Bloody hell!" one of their mates behind Jack cursed. "No one told us we'd be fighting Superman!"

Jack clenched his teeth to keep from correcting the soldier. Teal'c was closer to Captain America, not Superman, but it wouldn't do to appear a nerd. He turned and grinned. "Welcome to the galaxy, boys! Don't worry, with training, you'll be able to handle Jaffa."

Another soldier scoffed. "And with artillery."

"No heavy artillery for Stargate Command, alas." Jack smiled. "But anything portable, we can use."

"Why don't we get heavy weapons?" the soldier complained.

“Because our task is exploration and scouting - and guarding scientists and diplomats,” Jack quoted their new mission statement. “We’re not going to conquer planets.”

“Well, we should!” the soldier insisted.

“Hey! Even artillery wouldn’t hit the guy when he’s right in your trench!” another limey said. “Besides, we got his number now. When it’s our turn, we’ll get him for sure!”

Jack didn’t bother hiding his grin. Just like his latest batch of recruits, they had to learn the hard way.

*****

“So, how is it…” Daniel took a step back from where he had joined Jack O’Neill when Teal’c tossed another Russian across the mats in the base’s gym.

“...going?” Jack grinned. “As expected.”

The Russian cursed and rolled to his feet, then charged in again. Teal’c used one Jaffa-martial arts move Jack didn’t remember the name of and redirected the Russian’s charge into the other Russian trying to sneak up on him from behind.

Both went down in a tangle of limbs. When they got up, one had a split lip, and the other was favouring his left leg.

“Let’s take him all together!” the first spat in Russian.

“They didn’t say we could.”

“They didn’t say we couldn’t.”

“It makes us look bad.”

“I don’t care! Just take this bastard down!”

Jack chuckled loudly, which made the Russians sitting around the mat glare at him - they would know he spoke enough Russian to

understand them - but the four fighting Teal'c didn't seem to care and attacked together.

It didn't help them. Teal'c blocked two strikes, took a kick to his chest and slammed the first Russian down, then tackled two more. All went down, but only Teal'c got up, catching the last one with a mule kick in the chest.

Jack winced - he knew how much that hurt. Dr Fraser wouldn't be happy - she never was when they flooded the infirmary with training accidents. But this was necessary to avoid flooding the morgue once they were in the field.

Anyone with SGC needed to know just how dangerous Jaffa could be.

"They'll think every Jaffa is Teal'c," Daniel commented in a low voice.

"Yes. Better than thinking they are pushovers."

"They might be more easily intimidated when they meet the first Jaffa," Daniel worried.

"Doesn't matter. They'll still fight as well as they can." Jack knew those people. Spec Ops and Black Ops. And some spies. He glanced at the woman he had noticed before. She was getting ready to fight Teal'c next. She was wearing camo pants and a t-shirt that left her arms bare, and Jack studied her muscles. Definitely no desk jockeying data analyst. And not a honey trap, either. Or not just a honey trap. And she moved like… well, not quite like Teal'c, or Catra, but… Jack wouldn't like to fight her on the mats. Not because he wouldn't win - he had about fifty pounds of muscle on her and fifteen years of experience, and that would be telling - but it would be closer than he would like. And he would get hurt.

"Are you sure about that, Jack?"

“Yes. I know the type.” Jack would do the same in their place. Had done the same.

“Well, if you’re sure that…” Daniel trailed off when more Russians started flying. Not the woman, though - she evaded Teal’c and almost caught him in the back. And she took two throws to stay down.

Yeah, Jack would have to keep an eye on her.

*****

Heathrow Airport, London, United Kingdom, Earth, September 23rd, 1998

“Horses!” Adora couldn’t help it - she beamed as they stepped out of Darla. There were two carriages waiting for them with horses! And more people on horses! Swift Wind would love this! Or not - he probably would want those horses freed.

“Did they put this together to impress us?” Catra asked, looking around with a barely-hidden scowl.

“No,” Glimmer said. “This is standard procedure for state visits.”

“We checked,” Bow added.

Adora nodded. He had researched things.

“And you didn’t tell us?” Catra asked with a frown.

“I thought Adora would tell you,” Glimmer replied before taking a step forward and greeting their hosts - represented by the Crown Prince, apparently, and a minister of the government.

And lots of horses. And, of course, lots of reporters.

“I hope they have more effective security than horse cavalry,” Catra muttered after a frown at Adora.

“Smile,” Adora whispered before she shook the Prince’s hand. He looked about as old as Micah.

They exchanged the usual greetings. By now, Adora was kind of familiar with the customs. Shake hands, say how happy you are to be here, smile and wave for the cameras - that came before, when you left the shuttle or ship - and don’t say anything too honest.

After the spiel, they climbed into the waiting carriages. Glimmer and Bow rode with the Prince, Adora and Catra with the minister - the Foreign Secretary.

“We’re using standard protocols for visiting royalty,” the man explained as they took off, travelling at low speed.

Adora nodded. “Of course.” They were princesses, after all. And their consorts - even if it wasn’t yet official. But that didn’t seem to matter to the British. Though Catra suspected that they would care about those details if they didn’t have to suck up to the Alliance.

By the time they reached Windsor Castle, they had covered the landmarks on the way, the history of the Horse Guards, food and the weather. No politics. And Adora didn’t even have to pinch Catra to keep her lover from making comments about figurehead princesses and queens.

Such as the one they were meeting now. She was old. Adora had known that, of course - she had seen pictures and met her son today - but actually meeting her made that even more apparent. She wasn’t like Angella. And not like Madame Razz, either. No disapproving glances or absent-minded remarks.

The protocol for meeting the Queen was supposedly complicated, but it was nothing compared to the rules for the Princess Prom, so Adora didn’t make any mistakes while greeting the Queen or walking down the line of soldiers. It wasn’t an actual inspection,

though - the Queen didn't check every soldier for regulation-conforming uniform, nor did she check their weapons.

Unlike the French, the British didn't have them proceed to the signing of the alliance treaty right away. First, they moved, again with the carriages, to the Queen's palace. Without the Foreign Secretary this time. And past a lot of people, many of them waving tiny flags of the United Kingdom and the Alliance.

"Let's hope none of them tries to kill us," Catra mumbled. Her ears were twitching - she was on edge, Adora realised.

Well, they were surrounded by throngs of people. And Adora knew that not everyone on Earth liked them. But here, she didn't see any signs of a protest. Just cheering people. And lots of children.

*****

Buckingham Palace, London, United Kingdom, Earth, September 23rd, 1998

They were having tea. Adora had had tea before, but not like this. And not just because they were in the Queen's palace - Buckingham Palace. She'd had tea in palaces before. But not with so much food. And good food, at that - Catra was scarfing down those fish sandwiches. Adora preferred the scones, actually.

"So, how was growing up on Etheria as a princess?" the Queen's second-eldest grandson - the 'spare' according to Catra - asked. He was very young, barely fourteen. Two years younger than his elder brother. The whole Royal family was present, which was, as far as Adora could tell, unusual for state visits.

"You'd have to ask Glimmer that," she told him. "I grew up as a Horde cadet."

"Yeah," Catra cut in after swallowing her latest sandwich. "We grew up in the barracks. Glimmer's the one who grew up in a palace."

Glimmer frowned slightly. “I was trained as a soldier as well,” she said.

“In a palace.” Catra grinned. “With good food and beds so soft, you could drown in them.”

Adora nodded. “Oh, yes. I remember my first night at Bright Moon. I couldn’t sleep because it was so soft.” And because she had missed Catra’s presence, but she wouldn’t talk about that.

“We’re going to enter the military as well,” the young prince told them, nodding solemnly before grinning. “We might even get to fight the Goa’uld, too! Like Uncle Andrew fought the Argentines.”

Adora hid a grimace. She wasn’t the only one, she saw - the Queen wasn’t amused. She looked like Angella right then, just older.

“We shall do our duty,” the Queen said. “As we have done before.”

She had served in the army as well, or something like it, according to Bow. And her consort had been in the Navy. Like proper princesses.

“Nazis, Argentines, and now snakes,” the old man - a prince as well, although now he was the Royal Consort - said with a chuckle. “I wonder what’s next. Martians?”

Mars was not inhabited… Oh, he was joking again. Sometimes, it was hard to tell. And some of the consort’s jokes were… a little mean. Catra liked them, though.

Adora nodded and took another scone.

“We can’t actually be sure that there aren’t other realms in the galaxy that might be a threat to us,” Glimmer said. “Just because we haven’t encountered them so far doesn’t mean they don’t exist.”

“Yes,” Bow agreed. “The galaxy is so big, the Goa’uld Empire is a very small part of it. And they limit themselves mostly to the worlds linked by Stargates. We’ve encountered several different species while we’ve dealt with Horde Prime and they didn’t use Stargates as far as we know.”

Species like the Star Children or Melog, whose worlds had been destroyed by Horde Prime. Adora bit a little harder into her scone. So much pain and suffering, so much destruction just because of one man’s desires…

“Species like you?” the youngest prince asked, looking at Catra.

“Huh?” Catra shook her head. “No, I’m from Etheria.” She patted Melog’s head. “They’re such a species - Horde Prime destroyed their world.”

Melog growled softly for a moment.

“And they remember,” Catra went on. “They also remember the Goa’uld.”

For a moment, no one said anything. Then the Queen nodded. “Such atrocities must be remembered lest they will be repeated.”

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “We won’t let anyone destroy another world if we can help it.” She flashed her teeth in a grim smile.

“And we will do what we can to help you,” the Queen said.

Adora half-expected their hosts to point out that they could do more to help if they had advanced technology, but no such comment followed. Then again, the Queen was just the figurehead, not the ruler of the country.

“So, how many different species do live on your planet?” the older of the two princes asked, leaning forward a little.

He was addressing Catra as well, Adora noticed with a slight smile.

"Lots. I don't know how many, actually. But there has to be a list in some archive. Or in the research base on the moon," Catra replied.

"A research base on the moon?" The younger prince blinked.

"Yes," Bow told him. "The reason we have so many different species on Etheria is that the First Ones created them as part of their research using genetic engineering. All of Etheria's species are related to humans like yourself."

"Ah." The boy nodded.

And the First Ones had also built a superweapon into Etheria's core to destroy Horde Prime, but that wasn't the time to mention this, in Adora's opinion. "The First Ones were destroyed by Horde Prime as well," she said instead. All but herself. Although Jack also was a First One, so… there probably were more people like her left. On Earth, even.

But that was another topic not suited to this conversation.

"So, can you breed with humans?" the Royal Consort asked Catra.

Catra shrugged. "Sure." She glanced at Adora for a moment and then grabbed another sandwich.

"Any species on Etheria can have children with another species, though they might need magical help in some cases," Bow said. "We haven't any, ah, data on how it works with other species not related to humans, but theoretically, you could use the same methods the First Ones used to create Etheria's species to create offspring."

The Royal Consort laughed at that. "Oh, that will ruffle some feathers!"

"The ramifications for various legislation will be quite complicated," the Queen said. "We will have to bring that up in

Our next talk with the Prime Minister. It wouldn't do to be caught unaware by one of Our subjects having offspring with an alien."

"Or an animal," the Royal Consort added with another chuckle.

The Queen didn't seem to be amused but she slowly nodded. "Quite."

The young princes grimaced, and the Crown Prince frowned. "That seems rather far-fetched," he commented. "And such magic would be restricted, wouldn't it?"

"Probably not," Glimmer replied. "Don't you have myths about horse people?"

"Centaurs," Bow corrected her. "And there were minotaurs mentioned as well. Earth magic might make this possible. Technology certainly will, once you master First Ones tech."

"We really must have a talk with the Prime Minister." The Queen lifted her cup of tea and took a sip.

Glimmer frowned. "Can you actually tell him what to do? We were told that the power rests with the elected government."

The Queen smiled. "It's not quite as cut and dry as it sounds. The power does rest with the government. However, the reasons for that are a mix of custom, tradition and laws. And as Queen of England, we wield influence - soft power. The Prime Minister cannot easily dismiss our concerns, certainly not if they are well-founded."

"Which the prospect of people having kids with their pets certainly qualifies as," the Royal Consort added. "I can think of a few people who would have rather married their dog than their spouse."

"Animals cannot consent to marriage, though," Glimmer retorted. "Only sapient species can. You couldn't marry a pet. Well, not according to our laws."

"Nor according to ours," the Queen said. "But we are more concerned about genetic engineering creating new species. Even leaving aside the moral questions about mixing humans and animals, what about the practical aspects? People rarely succeed at their first attempt when they are trying something new, and while a craftsman discarding a ruined piece is normal, we would rather not see people discarded - or suffer from mistakes made in their creation that leave them in pain or crippled."

It was Adora's turn to wince. The Queen was correct; people trying to create a new species would likely make mistakes while experimenting. Even worse, she had a feeling that this was a problem the First Ones - her people - had had to deal with when they experimented in Etheria. She wasn't sure she wanted to know what they had done with 'failed experiments'. Even though the answer was probably buried in all the data from the research base.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 23rd, 1998

"So, this is a zat'nik'tel. Weird design. But powerful. And non-lethal. Boon for police, you think?"

Samantha Carter shook her head at her new colleague. "Two shots kill, three disintegrate, Iwan." Far too easy to kill someone before you realised that you had hit them the first time.

"Make it one shot only?" He cocked his head sideways and frowned at the weapon he was holding. "And limit it to one per squad?"

"Reducing the number of shots - or introducing a hard-coded delay so it would be safe - would mean you'd have to hit with the first shot," she explained. "And that would mean it would only see marginal use. Especially in incidents with multiple assailants." She had had to explain that to a senator before. At least no one had

told the NRA yet that there were actual stun and disintegration ray guns on Earth.

“Ah.” He nodded. “Too bad. Reliable method of non-lethal takedown would be great. Especially for hostage situations.”

“Yes. But not even the Etherians have anything like that.” Although they might have some spells which could be used for that. Sam hadn’t asked.

He put the gun down and beamed at her. “So! What work do you do?”

“I’m waiting for Entrapta to arrive,” she said. “We’re working on space surveillance drones.” The princess apparently had overslept - after working through the night. Or so Hordak had claimed.

“Great! Space spy drones!” Dr Georgovich clapped his hands together. “You go to space to test, da?”

Sam nodded. She felt almost nostalgic - he was so enthusiastic about space. When was the last time Sam had felt like that? After weeks in space, and several visits to orbit, it had become almost mundane. Of course, all the urgent work piled on her had done its share of taking the wonder out of space travel.

“Is something wrong?”

“No, no.” She smiled. “I was just thinking about all the other projects waiting for me.” Some of which she wouldn’t be allowed to work on, now that she was - technically - under the command of the United Nations.

“Oh! What other projects do you work on?” He looked around.

Now that was a little blatant. “Currently? I don’t know.” She inclined her head with a slightly toothy smile. “Others are going over the classified material to see what will be moved.” She suppressed a frown. That was logical, but she still didn’t like it.

"Oh." He pouted, then shrugged. "Like in Russia, then. Secret Service controls science."

"Not quite," she told him with a frown. "But not all the work I did was for Stargate Command."

"But you cannot decide what work was and was not, da? Secret Service can classify it."

She kept herself from frowning. "That is out of my hands. I focused on science, not internal or international politics." Technically true, even though she had followed either as well.

"Ah." He nodded with a wide smile. "Again, like Russia! Or USSR!"

It wasn't like that. But saying so would make her look petulant. So she shrugged. "Perhaps. Now, the work on spy drones involves Etherian technology. Horde technology."

"Ah!"

Yes, that would interest Dr Georgovich. He hadn't yet asked if he was allowed to work with Entrapta, but was that because he was aware that this wasn't covered by the new agreement with the United Nations or because he knew that this was entirely up to the Etherians and he hoped that Entrapta would invite him to work with them?

If so, he might be disappointed. Entrapta would do so in a heartbeat, Sam was certain, but Hordak wouldn't. The former warlord had more of a mind for keeping things classified than Entrapta.

"In any case, we have work to do for Stargate Command. Recalibrating for stellar drift, for one." That was needed to keep the Stargate working with their computers.

"Oh. That's what Russian DHD does automatically, da?"

"Yes. But we shouldn't just rely on an artefact we can't duplicate," she retorted.

"Da! We need to learn how to build DHD!"

Oh, if Sam achieved that… It wasn't just the controls for the Stargate or the software, but the power sources… "Let's start with the charts," she said. "We got a lot of astronavigation data from the Etherians and still haven't implemented everything yet."

"Da! Let's do science!"

*****

"Sam?"

Samantha Carter looked up from the latest readouts when she heard Daniel enter her lab. "Yes?"

"Do you want to do lunch together?"

She narrowed her eyes at her friend. Was he being subtle about 'feeding our scientist', as the Colonel put it, or did he just want to eat with her? It was hard to tell with Daniel.

"Lunch? Oh. Already past noon!" Dr Georgovich exclaimed. "Time to eat! Cannot live on coffee and tea, no matter how much sugar we add, da?"

Daniel blinked, apparently surprised by Dr Georgovich inviting himself along. "Ah… yes." He looked at Sam again.

Was something wrong? If something had happened to the Colonel or Teal'c, Daniel would have said so right away. Was it about the Russians? The Colonel was training the new arrivals today.

"So, let's go? Before only spam is left?" Dr Georgovich was beaming at them.

Daniel nodded. "Ah, OK!"

Sam almost snorted as she followed them out of the lab. "So, will the Colonel and Teal'c be joining us?"

"I don't think so," Daniel said. "Teal'c told me that they will be eating 'in the field' when he came to grab his mess kit."

"How did the training go so far?" Sam asked as they waited for the lift to arrive.

"As expected, I think. Teal'c wasn't very talkative."

Sam chuckled.

"Strong and silent type, yes?" Dr Georgovich asked.

"Ah, yes." Daniel nodded. "Though he also said that Jack was interested in a female soldier."

Sam blinked. What?

*****

10 Downing Street, London, United Kingdom, Earth, September 23rd, 1998

"...and I'm happy and proud to see this historic agreement signed today!"

It was hard to think of the Queen as a mere figurehead after meeting her, Catra had to admit. Even harder when meeting the Prime Minister right after having had tea with her. He was trying too hard to be nice, in Catra's opinion.

Of course, he wanted this alliance signed, so he had to be nice. But, still… Catra refrained from scowling when everyone present clapped their hands. And his smile was a bit too wide. He just… didn't look like a princess. Or prince, in his case. And he didn't live in a palace. It was a big house, of course, but it wasn't a proper palace. Unlike the French President's palace.

Of course, the French didn't have a queen, so their president filled the spot, so that was probably why he got to have a palace - no princess to show up.

"As are we." Glimmer stood straight, but she wasn't trying to appear taller than she was in an attempt to match the Prime Minister. "We are looking forward to fighting side by side with your troops against the Goa'uld to free their slaves."

More applause while some flunkie presented the alliance agreement to them. A few strokes with a pen later, they had their alliance.

And even more clapping followed. Well, they finally had their second alliance in the bag. And the Germans would follow tomorrow.

So, it was time to celebrate. Only, they had to face the press next. Like with the French. Catra kept smiling while she stared at a dozen cameras and more microphones. "Imagine if we had to deal with that back home," she whispered to Adora as they lined up for the questions.

"Shh!" Adora hissed back.

"You know I'm right." Catra had the last word.

Then the questions began.

*****

"I'm sorry, but as the Prime Minister already told you, we cannot comment on plans and missions." Catra saw that Adora's smile was frozen as she answered the same question the Prime Minister had already answered. For the third time.

"Audrey Collins, BBC. Prime Minister, are you planning to reintroduce military conscription? According to our sources, the British Army currently has just shy of fifty thousand soldiers available for deployment. This seems quite low for a galactic war."

The man's smile didn't waver. "We're looking into all options once we have a clearer picture of what exactly the military situation demands. Of course, I hope that we will not be forced to reintroduce conscription."

"Does that mean you support extending the alliance with Etheria to countries with more soldiers available for deployment, regardless of their human rights record?"

"That question hasn't been raised so far."

"It seems to be an obvious question. It hasn't been brought up so far?" The woman's frown was impressive.

Adora cleared her throat. "As I have said before: We cannot comment on plans and missions at this point."

"And that includes future diplomatic overtures." Glimmer frowned. "However, we have no intention to lower our standards and ally with people who would discriminate against us."

"Tim Brown, the Sunday Times. Isn't that a form of discrimination?"

That again! Catra rolled her eyes as Glimmer glared at the fool: "Do you think you have a right to our technology? That we have an obligation to share it with everyone, regardless of their deeds and character? Regardless of their stance towards us?"

"No, of course not, but some might consider your stance as forcing everyone to accept your values and morals."

"All we require is to treat people like us - people loving the same gender - equal to others. If that violates your morals, then that says a lot about your morals, but nothing good." Glimmer bared her teeth.

The reporters in France had been much more polite. Or picked better.

“Stop shilling for bigots, Tim!” someone from the reporters yelled. “We’re here to get information, not push conservative policy!”

“Indeed,” the Prime Minister said. “Ken?”

“Ken Smith, The Guardian. Will you send teachers and instructors to Britain to proliferate technology or invite students to Etheria or both?”

Glimmer glanced at Bow, who took a step towards the microphone. “We’re still evaluating how we can share our technology in the most efficient way. However, transporting large numbers of people to Etheria seems not very efficient even with the Stargate, not when the industry to be converted is here.”

And it would also flood Etheria with spies. Though saying so would be rude. Which was why Adora had told Catra she couldn’t comment on that. Spoilsport.

“Karen Calloway, The Independent. Will there be a supreme commander for the Alliance?”

“Why wouldn’t there be a supreme commander?” Adora looked as surprised at the questions as Catra. Of course there would be a supreme commander! You couldn’t wage war effectively without one person in charge. Trying to fight a war under a committee was a recipe for disaster, as the Princess Alliance had found out early on. “It would be foolish not to fight under a unified command.”

“And who would be that commander?”

“That remains to be seen. None of us has experience waging war against the Goa’uld, so we can’t tell yet who’s best at it.” Adora nodded with a smile. “I think it will take a while to find the right person.”

“And to convince them to take the job,” Catra added with a grin. “Those who have been in command of an army at war before know what I mean.”

But it was a good question - who would lead the alliance forces? Adora? Glimmer? Not Hordak. And certainly not any of the other princesses. Adora would be best - Catra could work best with her.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 23rd, 1998

"...and the Etherian delegation is currently attending the state dinner in Buckingham Palace. According to usually well-informed sources, informal talks following the signing of the alliance have gone well, and concrete results are supposed to be released soon. Neither the Etherians nor Her Majesty's Government was willing to comment, though, so speculation is running rampant."

Sitting in the mess hall, Jack O'Neill rolled his eyes at the reporter on the screen. Of course they wouldn't comment on informal talks - or release anything before the alliance agreement with the Germans was signed and the Etherians could actually start hashing out concrete details with the limeys, the Germans and the French.

Well, there were rumours that at least half the smaller European countries wanted to join the alliance - like the Swedes and the Finn, once they worked out how to handle their neutrality. That might delay the whole process further. Or the big three might just go ahead anyway and expect the smaller countries to follow their lead. Jack had a feeling that the last thing the Europeans wanted was to have the United States join the alliance too soon. Or at all.

To quote the limeys he had trained today in the field: bloody wankers. They were in this together - all of Earth was. They had to work together to defeat the Goa'uld. Though Jack wouldn't mind if the Russians and the Chinese were a little less involved.

He glanced over at the table where most of the Russian soldiers were sitting. How many of them were spies? It was hard to tell. All of them had military experience; Jack had confirmed that

today. But how many had training as spooks? Some didn't hide their interest in everything in the Mountain, whether or not it was part of Stargate Command, but were they spies - or just distractions for the real spooks? Or was it a triple bluff?

He studied the woman who had caught his attention earlier. Lt Svetlana Lenkova. She was most certainly a spook - she had combat experience, Jack was sure of that, and women weren't allowed to serve in combat units in the Russian army. According to her file, she was a communication specialist, but he had seen her shoot and fight in close quarters, and he'd eat his service cap if she was a radio operator with basic combat training. The way she sat, a little too relaxed, and the way the Spetsnaz soldiers listened to her was another clue. No special forces would act like that towards a radio operator. Certainly not with one as pretty as the woman.

"Jack?"

He blinked and turned to Daniel. "Yes?"

"You were staring at the Russians."

"Yes?" Why wouldn't he stare at them? They were a security risk. This was still an American base, no matter whether or not the Stargate was now UN property or whatever.

"So, Teal'c was correct - you're interested in the blonde."

"What?" He blinked again.

"He said that she caught your attention." Daniel was… not quite frowning.

"Indeed." Teal'c nodded.

And Carter… was focusing on her meal. Probably going over some data in her head that Entrapta had brought up in the afternoon or something.

“Well, yes,” Jack told his friend. “I’m sure she’s a spy.”

“A spy?” Daniel looked surprised. And Carter stopped eating to stare at Jack.

He sighed. Daniel was a little naive, but Carter should’ve known better. “Yes. I’m sure she’s GRU. Russian military intelligence,” he added for Daniel’s benefit.

To his friend’s credit, he didn’t ask if that meant KGB. “So, that’s why you’re interested in her?”

“Yes?”

“Ah.”

Jack narrowed his eyes. What was Daniel thinking? Or implying? Oh, for crying out loud! “Do you really think I would fall for a honey trap?” He scoffed and shook his head.

And caught Lenkova smiling a rather toothy smile at him. Had she been watching him? She couldn’t have been listening in, but if she could read lips… He bared his own teeth at her in a wide smile. She might be a lethal GRU agent, but Jack had decades of experience in black ops.

Let’s see who comes out on top, he thought.

*****

The Expert

Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 23rd, 1998

"I'm dying."

Adora rolled her eyes at Catra. "You aren't dying. You just stuffed yourself."

"Against my will. This was an attempt to kill us. A very subtle and cunning attempt. All those fish dishes… they knew I would be unable to resist." Catra groaned from their bed. "I'll get back at them for that."

"They just wanted to curry favour with you," Adora told her as she finished putting her clothes into their locker - or armoire since it was in their cabin. It was her best dress, after all, and deserved to be cared for. It would be a little embarrassing if she had to ask an Earth tailor for another dress.

Not that that deterred Catra. Her lover had dropped her clothes on the floor on the way to the bed. And not in the sexy way - she had groaned and complained until she hit the bed.

Adora sighed and started picking up the pieces.

"Just leave it for the bots. They need to be cleaned anyway," Catra commented from the bed.

Adora pressed her lips together. "It's still not right to just drop stuff on the floor."

"We're not cadets any more."

"That's no excuse."

Catra snorted. "I'd say you're making the job harder for the bots - they need to get it out of the locker now."

She had a point, but Adora wouldn't admit that. You just didn't leave your clothes on the floor. Unless you were seducing your lover, of course - it would kill the mood if you started gathering the clothes. Even Adora knew that.

So she still put the clothes into Catra's locker, sent a message to the bots to get it cleaned, as well as her dress, and then finally joined Catra on the bed.

"Took you long enough," Catra complained.

"It seems you have survived the cunning attack on your life."

"The fish I can't stomach has yet to be born. Not counting fugu."

"Fugu?"

"Some poisonous fish people eat on Earth. Deadly poison."

"They eat poisonous fish?" Were they crazy? Crazier than Adora had thought?

"Well, they cut the poisonous part out or something. Unless the cook makes a mistake, it's perfectly safe." Catra shrugged - a bit too nonchalantly.

Adora knew her lover. "You're not going to eat that fish." No one was perfect, after all. Everyone made a mistake at least once.

Catra frowned at her. "I didn't say I was going to eat it."

"I know you were planning to eat it."

"I wasn't really planning to eat it. We aren't even planning to visit Japan. And I don't think they would serve it at a state dinner, anyway."

Adora narrowed her eyes. That was a lot of research into a fish. "Of course they wouldn't serve poisonous fish at a state dinner!" Because it was poisonous!

“So, there’s no reason to worry about me.” Catra grinned widely.

There was only one answer to that. Adora slid over, then rolled on top of her lover. “I do worry about you anyway. Because I know you,” she said, looking down at Catra.

“Well, you shouldn’t. I survived fighting you,” Catra retorted.

Adora suppressed a sigh. That was typical for Catra, mentioning the war to change the subject. “I worry anyway,” she repeated herself.

Catra bit her lower lip. “I know,” she whispered after a moment, glancing to the side. And blushing under her fur.

Adora smiled and bent down, planting a kiss on her lips. And another. And then a third, longer one, when Catra wrapped her arms around her.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 24th, 1998

Glimmer and Bow were already at the table when Adora entered Darla’s kitchen with a yawning Catra in tow. Hordak and Entrapta were probably still asleep - they had worked late into the night.

“So… what dastardly plans of us have the news revealed now?” Catra asked as she grabbed some bread and butter.

“The usual,” Glimmer replied. “Blah blah forced laws on us blah blah unfair discrimination blah blah plan to corrupt our youth blah blah weak government blah blah corruption at the highest level blah blah global conspiracy.”

She must have watched quite a lot of the news already, Adora realised.

“Well, most were quite positive,” Bow amended. “Just a few channels and newspapers were… critical.”

"And all of them are owned by the same people," Glimmer said. "Most belong to the same person, even. At least in England and America."

That was… well, not surprising. "Should we talk to them? Explain that we aren't corrupting anyone?" Adora asked.

"Won't help if they're a bigot," Glimmer said. "But they might just expect a bribe," she added. "They might want something in exchange for stopping this. They aren't as… fanatical as the others who hate us."

Adora frowned. "They are trying to blackmail us?" That was…

"Not blackmail, more like… extortion," Bow corrected her.

"It doesn't matter whether they hate us or want to extort something." Glimmer scoffed. "We have many more important people to talk to."

"But we could ask the Americans what's up with them," Catra suggested. "Have them do something about that. I mean, not that we would ask that, but I bet they would do something if we mentioned that this was annoying."

That was… likely, actually, but Adora didn't think it would be a good thing to do. It felt wrong. "I don't think that's a good idea," she said.

"Yes," Glimmer agreed. "The Americans might think that we owe them for anything they do."

Adora frowned again. That wasn't why she thought they shouldn't do this.

*****

"So… did you find anything that I missed and that we should be aware of during our trip to Germany?" Adora asked when

breakfast was over - well, almost over; Catra was finishing the scrambled eggs.

"We didn't actually do any research after yesterday's state dinner," Bow told her.

"As if you'd have missed anything," Catra said after swallowing. "You obsess over that stuff."

"I like to be prepared," Adora defended herself. "And the better we understand the Tau'ri, the fewer problems we'll have."

"Half of the time, nobody can understand them. Probably not even Earth people themselves," Catra said with a chuckle.

Everyone laughed, though it was a problem. Misunderstandings could have tragic consequences, as Adora and her friends knew very well. "Well, I don't think we'll have any problem at the signing. We didn't have any trouble in France or Britain, and they're supposed to be similar countries." She had mapped out some differences, but most of them didn't seem to apply. Except for the whole thing about the world war. The Second World War. As long as Catra didn't ask about the war, they should be fine. Though, speaking of the war… "What do you think about the supreme commander question?"

"It's a no-brainer," Catra said. She scoffed. "Without a unified command, we'll be as bad as the Alliance was before you took over."

"Hey!" Glimmer protested. "Adora didn't take over - we had to restore the Princess Alliance because it had fallen apart at that point. That was why the Alliance was so ineffective!"

Catra shrugged. "Same thing - you had no overall commander."

"It's not the same thing!"

Bow shook his head. "Let's not argue about the Alliance, OK?"

Adora nodded emphatically before Glimmer and Catra could continue their disagreement. “Yes. We all know we need a commander. The question is: Can we persuade our allies on Earth of that? And who will take the post?”

“Why would they baulk at this? They aren’t that stupid,” Catra said. “They had one in the big war as well. At least one per front or something.” She grinned. “And I think we can persuade them - we’ve got the fleet and the technology they want.”

That was a good argument. But… “And who would become supreme commander?” Adora asked.

“Not one of theirs,” Catra said at once. “They have no experience with our technology or war in space.”

“We don’t have much experience with a war in space either,” Adora pointed out. Well, she had personally cut fighters in half, but…

“It’s still more than they have.” Catra grinned. “And the clones have lots of experience - and Priest will follow you.”

Adora grimaced. That was true, but she didn’t like being reminded of it. “Still, we can’t let them lead us.” The only clone with actual experience as a commander in a war was Hordak. And Adora didn’t think anyone except, possibly, Entrapta would want him to lead the Alliance.

“But we have less experience fighting the Goa’uld,” Bow pointed out. “The Americans have been fighting them for years.”

“They aren’t in the Alliance,” Catra retorted.

“But they might join,” Bow told her. “They are making progress with their reforms.”

“And they have access to Goa’uld technology and a ship of their own,” Adora added. “They could fight without an alliance - they

did that so far. And they have the Stargate, so they can keep fighting the Goa'uld."

"The whole planet has access to the Stargate," Catra said. "Technically." She flashed her teeth in a grin.

"If we don't get them all united under one command, this will be a mess," Adora said. "But we can't ally with countries where we would get imprisoned - or worse - for loving each other."

Glimmer nodded. "Fortunately, the British and the French are part of the Security Council. If the Americans join the Alliance, that would mean they could control the Stargate. At least to some degree."

"I don't think the other countries would let them control the Stargate," Bow said.

"But if the Americans join, they'll want to have command," Catra said. "Hey! We all talked to SG-1. Remember Daniel's lectures? They are used to being in charge. And they don't like following orders. Especially from princesses - remember the comments about you? And our age?"

Adora did remember those comments on their television. As if you had to be old to lead! Or male!

"Well, we can't let them be in charge," Glimmer said. "They're not even in the Alliance yet."

"We haven't launched any operation yet, either." Bow shook his head. "By the time we're ready for an attack on a planet, we might have an alliance with the Americans."

"That means we should have our structures down for the new Alliance before that happens," Glimmer said. "And I think one of us needs to be in charge."

"Priest will only follow Adora, anyway," Catra pointed out. "Not anyone from Earth."

Adora frowned, but her lover was likely correct. “But I could be a subcommander.” She beamed at Glimmer. “You could lead. You lead the Princess Alliance in the war.”

Glimmer didn’t look as enthusiastic as Adora had hoped.

Catra, though, did. “Yes. And you have the political experience and rank to wrangle all the others.”

Glimmer frowned. “I also have a kingdom to rule. Unlike in the war against the Horde, I wouldn’t be on Etheria for long.”

“Micah’s got that in hand,” Catra retorted. “Besides, can you see Adora dealing with all those Earth rulers and politicians?”

Adora frowned when both Bow and Glimmer nodded at Catra’s words. She wasn’t that bad! “What about you, Catra?” she asked with a wide smile.

“No chance. I’m used to leading the Horde, where I could tell everyone what to do and didn’t have to worry about a dozen princesses or rulers disagreeing.” Catra grinned. “It’s you or Glimmer.”

“Glimmer!” Adora said at once.

*****

Area 51, Nevada, United States of America, Earth, September 24th, 1998

“Don’t worry, Carter - you’ll be back working with these alien thingamabobs soon enough.”

Samantha Carter frowned as she turned away from her laptop, where she was cross-checking the inventory of the transport, to look at the Colonel. “I wouldn’t presume to forecast my future deployments, Sir.” And she wasn’t sure whether or not she wanted to work at Area 51 anyway, instead of at the Stargate - or join the still-developing Space Force.

“Oh, come on - this is the Air Force’s newest and most secret research facility!” The Colonel grinned. “Where else do you think the brass would send their best scientist?”

“Somewhere they can work with alien researchers without having to go through an hours-long security check?” Sam tilted her head for a moment, then went back to check off yet another piece of alien technology that hadn’t been fully identified yet. Probably part of a lattice used to grow crystals for data storage, but Sam hadn’t been able to get around to testing her assumption.

“Good point!” The Colonel nodded. “Security is tight here. Very tight.”

Sam half-expected him to make an off-colour joke about how tight it was, but he didn’t. He was correct, though - security had increased since her last visit. Of course, that had been before first contact with Etheria and all the troubles that this caused - Sam still winced when she thought of the attempted storming of the base by a mob.

But they might have overdone it a little. Daniel and Teal’c hadn’t been allowed on-site, presumably because their presence wasn’t needed. And because they were civilians. Sam couldn’t imagine foreigners, much less alien researchers, being allowed into the base. Having them land at the base was one thing, but entering the base proper was a completely different matter.

Which meant she didn’t really want to work here, either. Not to mention that the whole base was about applying alien technology, not groundbreaking research.

And, she added to herself as two transport containers were unloaded from the plane under even heavier security, now containment for alien prisoners as well. Apparently, the United Nations weren’t trusted with Seth or Osiris. Sam had pointed out that this would delay interrogation efforts that needed the Etherians’ help, but the transfer had gone through anyway. She wondered what would happen when the Etherians wanted to visit

- or check up on how the prisoners were treated. Well, that wouldn't be her problem, would it?

Once the two containers were put on trucks bristling with guards and driven out of the hangar, the Colonel spoke up again: "I don't like this. I can't help feeling that the resident nerds and brass underestimate the snakes."

"They will have read the reports and files," Sam said.

"Reports and files are well and good, but they can't replace practical experience. And what are the chances that someone who thinks he's smarter than he actually is comes up with some 'genius plan' that involves the Goa'uld?"

Like offering them some sort of host in exchange for cooperation? Too high, in Sam's opinion. She knew a number of the scientists working here. And some of them she wouldn't trust to look after a hamster. But it was out of their hands for now, with Stargate Command now under the control of the United Nations. "I wouldn't presume to make any estimates," she said.

The Colonel snorted but didn't press her. "Well, the Etherians will find them, should they escape. They've got that magic scanner, after all. But, in the interest of fostering good relations, someone ought to inform them of the transfer as well."

Was he asking her to do it? She was meeting Entrapta tomorrow - today's trip to Nevada took too long to do any more work with the princess - and it would be easy to tell her. She hadn't been ordered not to tell, after all. And Area 51 was supposed to be secret, but the Etherians had landed here for their first visit...

So she nodded. "It would certainly be rude to have them find out once they want to talk to them." Or think the Goa'uld escaped from Colorado.

"Exactly!"

The Colonel watched as the last container with alien technology was opened and both Sam and the local officer in charge went through the inventory. Nothing came up missing or unaccounted for, and the last truck soon left the hangar.

Half an hour later, they were back in the air on the way to Colorado. And catching up on the news.

"...and the crowds are already lining the streets in anticipation of the Etherians' arrival. Berlin is ready for the aliens!"

"But are the aliens ready for Berlin?" The Colonel snorted. "I've been there, actually, during the Cold War. How things have changed."

Sam knew better than to ask him about what he had been doing there. "After today, the Etherians will have an alliance with three of the most powerful countries in Europe."

He scoffed. "Just signing a treaty won't create a working alliance. They still have to hash out all the nitty-gritty details. Troops, command, missions, technology… It'll take a while until anything comes of this." With a chuckle, he added: "Just sorting out who is to be in charge will take a long while."

"I would assume Adora or Glimmer would be in command," Sam said.

"They're the logical choice. But both are young - I've had second lieutenants older than them. That will cause problems."

And their gender, Sam silently added. Many, probably most of the officers would have trouble following the orders of a young woman. She knew that better than most.

"And no one wants to let foreigners command their soldiers," the Colonel went on.

"Least of all the United States," Sam said.

He frowned at her reminder that the United States was working on an alliance with the Eherians as well, with all that entailed. "Yes. Working out who is in charge once we join will be difficult."

Mostly for the United States, in Sam's opinion. Given the discrepancy in experience and resources, the Etherians were the obvious choice for supreme command of Alliance forces in the field. The Colonel was aware of that as well, but she knew he didn't like it.

Sam wasn't entirely sold on it, either. It was logical, obvious, but… it took a lot of trust to let foreigners command your own troops. Who could say if they didn't favour their own troops, even just a little, over others? It was one thing to have a few troops under someone else's command, but all of them?

*****

Flughafen Berlin-Tegel, Berlin, Germany, Earth, September 24th, 1998

"As I said: The same as in Paris and London." Catra smirked as they stepped out of Darla. "Flags, soldiers and reporters. And a minister or two." Typical.

"Those aren't ministers. Those are the chief of the Bundespräsidialamt and his partner," Adora corrected her.

"Bundespre-what?" Catra asked.

"The office of the head of state of the Germans," Bow explained.

Right. The Germans were infamous on Earth for using weirdly long words. "Still the same. They're just here to greet us," she insisted.

Then they reached the bottom of the ramp, and the whole circus started. Formal greeting, walking past soldiers, past reporters - no answering questions, though - and then getting into cars. No carriages here.

The drive through Berlin felt the same as in Paris or London - lots of people waving and cheering, lots of flags, big and small ones, until they reached a sort of palace, where more soldiers and the German Bundespräsident waited. Now that was a figurehead, in Catra's opinion. No real power at all. And he wasn't like the Queen either. Friendly, but not princess material - she found that out quickly after they started talking in the palace.

"...so, you act as the highest judge?"

And he wasn't interested in their military but their judges. Talk about weird!

"Only for the worst crimes," Glimmer replied. "But those are really rare."

"Really?" The man looked surprised.

"Yes. The normal judges can handle pretty much everything." Gimmer nodded.

"That's surprising. And you pick the judges?"

"Yes. Though most were picked by my mother."

Catra didn't wince. She kept smiling politely, even though being reminded of one of her greatest mistakes - or crimes - that had led to Queen Angella sacrificing herself made her want to wince. She grabbed another snack to distract herself. Tuna salad canapés, those were called, and they were heavenly. She'd have to ask Sea Hawk or Mermista if Etheria had any fish like this.

"...and do you use magic to determine the truth?"

"Yes, when the judge or the people in court ask for it."

They were still talking about the law? Catra wanted to roll her eyes.

“Aren’t you concerned that this would force everyone to ask for magical means to prove they are telling the truth or be suspected of or assumed to be lying?”

Glimmer tilted her head with a frown. “Without truth, there is no justice. Why would we want to let people lie?”

“But what if people honestly believe that something is true? Would your magic detect a lie instead?”

“No. But it would still show what the person honestly believed, which is usually decisive for a case.”

“Usually, but there are always exceptions, aren’t there?”

“Few of them. And even those can be solved with care and attention. We…”

Catra tuned the discussion out. Who cared about the law when they had a war to fight? Especially if it wasn’t about war crimes? And why would the right to lie be a right at all? Hell, Double Trouble would love this system!

*****

Schloss Bellevue, Berlin, Germany, Earth, September 24th, 1998

“...and with this signature, the alliance has been officially formed!” the German Chancellor announced.

Finally! Catra clapped loudly and enthusiastically as applause filled the room. They were here to sign the treaty, not to discuss the finer points of the law. Worst meeting ever, in her opinion. Even if the food had been good. Better than expected, after what Adora had read up on German cuisine. At least they knew how to cook fish.

And now came the press. Gah! Catra blinked as cameras flashed.

“Hans Meier, FAZ. Herr Bundeskanzler, do you expect that this treaty will decide the upcoming election?”

The Chancellor slowly nodded. “Entering this alliance is one of the most important decisions I ever took for the future of Germany - on par with the reunification of our country. With this, we have assured the safety and future of Germany and its place at the forefront of technology.”

“Karl Reissmann, Der Spiegel. Herr Bundeskanzler, what do you say to the accusations that you made too many concessions to the Etherians in order to secure this alliance?”

“Those accusations are completely unfounded! All we conceded was the implementation of laws that should have been implemented long ago, to grant equal rights to all citizens and residents in Germany no matter their life choices.”

Yeah, the reporters were the same as well. They should have skipped this, in Catra’s opinion.

“Jasmin Kowalski, TAZ. Herr Bundeskanzler, how do you feel, having committed Germany to another war of conquest?”

“This comparison is in very bad taste - and wrong as well! We aren’t in a war of conquest; we are in a war for our very survival against an enemy that has enslaved countless planets.”

“And yet, according to what we know, the Bundeswehr will be expected to help conquer planets. Excuse me, ‘liberate’ them. Was a diplomatic solution even considered?”

Adora took a step forward. “We’re always open for a diplomatic solution - but not if it means accepting slavery. If the Goa’uld desire peace, all they have to do is liberate their slaves, both humans and Jaffa. And if we have to conquer their Empire to liberate their slaves, then we will do that. How would you feel, knowing that you could free a slave but deciding not to?”

"How will you feel, knowing that millions will die in a war that could have been prevented?"

Adora frowned at the woman. "As I said, if the Goa'uld want peace, they have to release their slaves. We will certainly give them the option."

Catra frowned as well. They hadn't discussed that yet with their new alliance members. And contacting the Goa'uld first would ruin the element of surprise. She suppressed a sigh. Sorting this out wouldn't be pretty.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 24th, 1998

"...and experts are divided in their views on whether or not the Goa'uld will respond to any diplomatic offer. Retired Colonel Barnes, United States Air Force, was cited that 'any such offer would be repeating the mistakes made in Munich in 1938', although several prominent activists have already launched a proposal to focus on a 'peaceful resolution of the current differences', and…"

Jack O'Neill wanted to shoot the television. 'Experts'? None of them had any experience with the Goa'uld - or with the Etherians or any other aliens. He had never even heard of Colonel Barnes, and, judging by his age, the man had retired from the Air Force before Stargate Command had been a thing. He definitely didn't know anything. Although Jack would grant him one thing - the man was correct that trying diplomacy with the Goa'uld was stupid. But those 'activists' calling slavery and genocide 'ideological differences'... "God damn it!" he cursed as he stabbed his jello - blue! - with his spoon. "I leave for half a day, and see what happens?"

"I do not think that you could have prevented Adora from voicing her views even if you had been present at the base, O'Neill."

“Da! Unless you have open channel to headphones of aliens, or ability to mute her microphone.”

Jack gritted his teeth. Why had the Russian spy - well, the most annoying of their spies - started to sit at their table? Because he had invited himself along when Jack had been in the field training the FNGs, and Daniel hadn’t had the balls to tell him to get lost. “It was a figure of speech,” he said. Daniel opened his mouth, and Jack shot him a glare. He wasn’t in the mood for pedantic linguistic corrections.

While Daniel pouted, Carter spoke up: “Adora didn’t actually make any offer - she merely stated what conditions she considers essential for a peace treaty and that she was open to a diplomatic solution. She didn’t announce that they would attempt to find a diplomatic solution before taking military action.”

“Yep. But everyone took it as a ‘peace for our time’ moment,” Jack said.

“Not everyone,” Daniel cut in, still pouting. “None of the involved governments, at least.”

“But the press did,” Jack retorted. “Until the Etherians clarify what they mean, people will keep arguing about this.” They would keep arguing after any clarification, of course, but it wouldn’t be as bad as it was right now. “They really should put out a communique.”

“They’re currently busy with the state dinner,” Daniel said.

Probably gorging them on good food. Well, decent food - they were in Germany, after all. “By the time they finish, some fools will have started building a Goa’uld hotel for the peace talks,” Jack said.

Daniel laughed, as did the Russian spy. “Funny! A snake hotel, like roach motel?”

“PETA would probably object,” Jack told him. Unfortunately, the man didn’t look confused but nodded, laughing again.

"It's just the media overreacting to every little slip of the tongue," Daniel said.

"And the politicians who think they can capitalise on this," Carter added.

"Damn vultures," Jack said. Them and their useful idiots. As if you could trust the Goa'uld to keep a treaty!

He finished his jello and looked around. The TV was showing some academic talking about how you couldn't truly understand real aliens' culture and what that supposedly meant for diplomacy with the Goa'uld. "What a nutcase!" he muttered.

"What a hypocrite!" Daniel hissed next to him. "Why would anyone give that charlatan the time of day, much less screen time?"

Jack blinked. "Is there a story here?" he asked his friend.

"Dr Baker was one of, well, my most vocal critics when I published my hypothesis," Daniel replied, scowling. "He called me a UFO conspiracy theorist. And now he's talking as if he were an expert on aliens! The man isn't even an expert in his own field - he needed help reading hieroglyphs!"

Ah, touchy subject. Jack nodded. "The actual experts are all working for us, so who could they drag in front of a television?" He shrugged.

"Someone who actually has an open mind!" Daniel answered his rhetorical question. "Not someone angling to agree with anyone who'd give him a grant!"

Really touchy subject.

"I should call the studio to set things straight. Baker's totally misrepresenting the Thirteenth Dynasty! Which has nothing to do with Goa'uld, anyway!" Daniel went on.

Jack blinked. That was… "I think you should call."

"What?" Everyone, not just Daniel, was staring at him. Even the Russian.

"What?" Jack frowned at them. "This isn't spilling some alien secrets - this is just Daniel correcting a colleague about Ancient Egypt."

"Right." Daniel nodded. "No talk about aliens, just Egypt." He stood and walked away.

Carter owned her mouth, then closed it and frowned at Jack. "You know they'll announce him as an expert on aliens."

"Of course. But Daniel's too smart to spill anything important." Jack grinned. And it might derail the damn peace talk frenzy.

"Really?" Carter's eyebrows rose. "You think Daniel will simply not comment when they ask questions about the Etherians and the Goa'uld? When they make up wrong statements about them?"

Jack blinked again. "On second thought, maybe I should go with him…"

*****

Schloss Bellevue, Berlin, Germany, Earth, September 24th, 1998

"...and I do not think that we should open with diplomacy. That would give away the advantage of surprise."

"Striking without a declaration of war? I think history shows why that's a very questionable plan."

"Are you comparing a war to defend ourselves and to free countless humans kept as slaves and hosts for parasites to a war of aggression?"

“No. But once we have struck, any offer to negotiate will either be seen as a ruse - or as a sign of weakness.”

Adora frowned at the discussion between the two German politicians. It seemed they had forgotten that this was a dinner, not their parliament. Or wherever they discussed like that.

“The Goa’uld don’t know about us,” Glimmer cut in. “Any negotiation will be difficult when one side doesn’t know the strength and goals of the other side.”

“And giving out that information would be stupid beyond belief,” Catra added.

“Then how are we supposed to negotiate in good faith with them?” the German asked.

“That’s easy: Once we have them at our mercy, we let them surrender.” Catra flashed her fangs at the man. “All honest-like.”

Adora chuckled almost against her will - and barely managed not to laugh when she saw the man’s reaction. So did Glimmer, and Bow hid his smile behind his napkin.

But the rest of the Germans, even the one who had argued against trying diplomacy first, didn’t look amused. Even the Chancellor frowned. “One should never enter a war lightly. Germany has a special responsibility there.”

“You mean because you started the last world war?” Catra asked, cocking her head.

“Germany did far more than starting a war,” the Chancellor replied. “The shadow of the crimes done in our country’s name - by our parents and grandparents - still lies over Germany.”

“Yeah, but this time, you’re on the right side,” Catra told him. “And that’s how you make up for your past crimes - by doing good.”

Adora nodded. “You are now helping to protect and free others. That’s the complete opposite of what your ancestors did.”

“But we can’t just ignore our past - Germany has a historic guilt.”

Adora frowned. That made no sense. “But you changed.”

“Yes,” Bow spoke up. “We studied your history. You have rejected your past ideology. Like others have.”

“Germany has a unique legacy. We carry a collective guilt. An obligation to ensure that this shameful, terrible history won’t ever repeat itself.” The big old man slowly nodded.

“But that’s exactly why we are fighting this war - will be fighting this war,” Glimmer protested. “To save millions of people from being enslaved and turned into hosts for the Goa’uld.”

“Or worked to death,” Bow added.

Adora nodded once more - they had seen the data Stargate Command had gathered on the Goa’uld’s practice of slavery.

“It’s still a difficult decision,” the Chancellor told them. “Germany will stand with you and with the other countries on Earth. We will defend ourselves and our allies - and there is no doubt that we are under attack, through no fault of our own. However, our history will not allow us to enter any war lightly, and even when we do, we should consider all alternatives before committing to war.”

“But none of you fought in the last war,” Glimmer said. “What happened wasn’t your fault.”

Adora looked around. None of the people present looked old enough to have fought in that war.

“I escaped that guilt by a hair’s width,” the Chancellor said. “I was already recruited and training to fight when the war ended.”

“Even if you had fought,” Adora told him, “you aren’t the same person you were back then - you changed.” She glanced at Catra, but her lover seemed very interested in the remains of dessert. “That’s what matters. The future, not your past.”

The Germans were staring at her, she noticed. At her, not at Catra.

“You do believe that,” one of the Ministers said, slowly shaking his head.

“Of course.” Adora nodded emphatically. “Everyone can change.” Her friends proved that. Catra proved that. “We hope the Goa’uld, too, will change. At least some of them.”

“So, you think we should talk before we start a war?”

Adora frowned. “We’re already at war. They started it long ago. They keep slaves. They use them as hosts. They attacked Earth - and I have no doubt that they would attack Etheria if they knew where we are.”

“Oh.”

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded sharply. “We will not refuse to talk with them if they offer an honest peace proposal - but neither will we stop fighting them. That would be a betrayal of all we stand for - and a betrayal of those who depend on us for their freedom or their very lives.”

Someone muttered ‘München’, but Adora didn’t know who it was.

“So, we’ll fight,” she went on. “And we’ll fight until all their slaves are free.”

“Whether that means we’ll fight to the last Goa’uld or not is up to them,” Catra said with a toothy grin.

As Adora and her friends nodded, she couldn’t help noticing that the Germans looked… surprised and concerned. “Do you

disagree?"

The Chancellor shook his head. "No. It's just… surprising to see people who have fought a war for years entering the next so… eagerly. You know how terrible war is."

Oh.

"We're willing to fight this war because we know the alternative," Glimmer said.

Adora nodded in agreement, but she couldn't help wondering if the Germans had a point.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 25th, 1998

"...and we are talking to Dr Daniel Jackson, who predicted the existence of aliens years before it was officially revealed. Dr Jackson, you wanted to chime in on our analysis of the Goa'uld?"

"Yes, Mr Ballantine. As you know, since you checked my credentials, I am a consultant for Stargate Command. In that capacity, I have met Goa'uld, and I am afraid that I disagree with the conclusions drawn by Dr Baker based on his studies of ancient Egypt, chiefly that we cannot understand a literal alien culture."

"Is this about my dismissal of your theory? Dr Jackson, back when you postulated the existence of aliens, you had no proof to prop it up. It was pure speculation."

"Speculation? I based my hypothesis on the results of various interdisciplinary research - results which were dismissed by everyone because they didn't fit established assumptions about the age of the pyramids. Instead of testing my hypothesis, which was what a scientist should have done, it was ridiculed. But that is not why I called today. I called because your lack of primary or secondary sources means your conclusions are incorrect."

"I have valid secondary sources!"

"You have, at most, tertiary sources. Hearsay, in other words. You have neither talked to any Goa'uld nor spoken with their subjects, much less visited their worlds."

"And you have?"

"Actually, I have, yes. And I can confidently state that your hypothesis that we cannot understand the Goa'uld is not supported by any evidence or experience. The Goa'uld aren't a misunderstood alien species with ethics incomprehensible for humans - their ethics are easily understood but simply reprehensible."

"That is a very biassed claim. Of course you'd say that, seeing as you work for the same organisation that started the war with the Goa'uld."

"Killing Ra was a reaction to his planned invasion of Earth. Any aggression started with him - I would know since I was there!"

Samantha Carter winced when General Hammond turned the television off. He was frowning, as were the other generals present. "I think there's no need to listen to the entirety of your scientific debate with Dr Baker, Dr Jackson."

Daniel flushed but stood his ground. "I merely corrected his mistaken assumptions about the Goa'uld."

"By citing your own experiences in the employ of Stargate Command," General Hammond said. "Which, I shouldn't have to remind you, are still classified."

"Daniel said nothing that was actually a secret," the Colonel spoke up. "Everything he mentioned was already publicly known."

"Yes. I did not reveal any details that might still be classified."

“Classified information isn’t automatically unclassified just because it’s leaked to the public,” General Sidorov cut in.

“Of course a Russian would say that,” Sam heard the Colonel mutter under his breath.

“That’s a very illogical stance,” Daniel retorted with a deep frown. “The President himself revealed the existence of Goa’uld, the Stargate Program, and our history with the Goa’uld, including the death of Ra.”

“You aren’t the President of the United States,” Sidorov shot back.

“And we aren’t in Russia,” the Colonel said. “If you expect us to keep silent about things everyone, including elementary students, is talking about, then I think you’ll be disappointed.”

“No one expects you to act as if this were still a secret,” General Hammond said. “However, neither does anyone expect you to act as if you were the spokesman of Stargate Command.”

Daniel flushed again. “I merely corrected quite mistaken claims by someone puffing himself up as an expert.”

“But you did so as an employee of Stargate Command,” General Haig said. “This means the public will consider your views as views shared by the entire program.”

“Views? I am talking about facts!” Daniel frowned. “I did not say anything about Stargate Command’s goals and policies; I just corrected factual claims that were wrong.”

Sam nodded. Her friend was correct - from a scientific point of view. Unfortunately, they were dealing with politics, not science.

“Without having received orders or permissions to do so.” General Li didn’t show any expression, but his tone indicated disapproval.

“I gave permission,” the Colonel said.

"You don't have the authority to do so, Colonel O'Neill," Li told him.

"I wasn't aware that Stargate Command had passed gag orders," the Colonel faked surprise. At least he didn't mention free speech in a dig against China and Russia. Small mercies.

"I doubt that such a call would have been permitted back when Stargate Command was an American program," General Haig said.

The Colonel shrugged. "Back then, it was a secret. Things change."

"Let's not mince words, Colonel." General Hammond was still scowling. "This wasn't just about correcting a scientist or settling academic grudges. This was about politics."

Daniel blinked, obviously surprised. Sam could see his eyes widen for a moment as he realised it.

The Colonel's equally obvious surprise, however, was faked. Sam was sure of that.

"The United States Armed Forces take a dim view of their members trying to make politics, Colonel O'Neill."

"Yes, Sir." The Colonel still didn't look concerned.

Well, he had good reasons not to be. Stargate Command couldn't afford to relieve him - or anyone else in SG-1. They needed their experience. And their connections to the Etherians.

But Sam had no doubt that whatever the timetable for their dismissal from Stargate Command was, it had just been accelerated to some degree.

Which probably had been the Colonel's goal. Or one of his goals.

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Cimmeria Part 1

Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 25th, 1998

"Whatcha watching?" Catra asked as she entered the lab in Darla's hold. There was some angry human on screen, yelling at the camera, and… She blinked. "Is that Daniel's voice?"

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "He's correcting the man's wrong assumptions about the Go'auld."

Catra cocked her head. "He is?" That was a surprise. So far, SG-1 hadn't appeared much in the media. "I would've expected him to be the focus of the show," she said.

"He's not present - he's just calling from the base," Entrapta replied. "And they don't have video calls." She frowned. "I don't know why - they could easily do this with their current technology. We have seen it work on television."

"They probably don't want video calls from their base to a television studio," Catra said. "Might be a security risk."

"Really?" Entrapta looked surprised.

Catra shrugged. "Maybe. I don't know." Etheria didn't have television. And Catra wasn't sure it needed it. Sure, the movies and series were entertaining, but all the talk shows… She made a gagging noise.

"What's wrong?" Entrapta peered at her.

"I believe she is regurgitating a 'hairball'."

Catra glared at Hordak. "No, I'm not. Just remembering some talk show."

"Ah. Which one?" Entrapta asked.

“Any one,” Catra replied, staring at the screen. The man was now standing and ranting about dynasties and hieroglyphs, with Daniel correcting every second word of his. She grinned when he corrected the man’s pronunciation - for such a friendly guy, Daniel could be surprisingly vicious in an underhanded way. Catra approved.

“This Dr Baker doesn’t seem like much of a scientist,” Entrapta said with a pout. “All his claims are unsubstantiated - or disproven. I expected a more interesting discourse.”

“I think I told you that we shouldn’t expect much scientific progress from daytime television,” Hordak told her.

“Yes, but… it’s such a waste! Imagine what research breakthroughs we could achieve if we connected the top scientists together like this!” Entrapta sighed. “And they use the technology to argue obviously false claims.”

“Just like their politics,” Hordak said.

Catra snorted. “Maybe you should suggest your plan to them.”

Entrapta nodded. “Yes! I’ll tell Sam about this. If it works, we will be able to do science all day! Even if you need Darla and the shuttle! And if we use remote-controlled bots, we can even work on the same prototype together without being in the same lab!”

That could work. Although… Catra grinned. “You could make a completely remote-operated lab. If it blows up, no one will get hurt.”

Entrapta beamed at her. “Oh, yes! That’s a great idea! We’ll finally be able to do those experiments that would be too dangerous to do on a planet!” She turned away and pushed buttons on her tool. “I’ll have to compensate for latency, and I’ll miss my hair for fine-tuning things, but… with the right manipulators, we can safely work on Naquadah-enhanced weapons!”

“Indeed. And the lack of air will mean we won’t have to worry about pressure waves devastating the planet,” Hordak agreed. “Although we should probably consider the danger from radiation.”

Catra blinked, then hit her palm against her forehead. She should have known better than to assume that Entrapta would be concerned about personal danger instead of danger on a planetary scale.

She looked at the screen, where Dr Baker was storming out of the studio in a rage, with Daniel asking when his hypothesis would be published. Ah, well… time to check how Adora was doing with Glimmer and Bow.

She left the hold - Entrapta and Hordak were already designing remote-controlled bots with manipulator arms - and swung by the kitchen to grab a salmon sandwich that she had sneaked out of the state dinner last night. It went perfect with some milk.

Munching and sipping alternately, she headed to the bridge.

“Finally awake… Ew!” Glimmer greeted her with a grimace.

“Ew?” Bow turned to look at Catra.

“I can smell the fish from here,” Glimmer complained.

Catra doubted that - she had already eaten most of it - but Adora stopped scribbling down notes on a board and sniffed the air. “I don’t… Do you think I’m getting a cold?”

“Nope,” Catra told her and walked over to them. She finished her sandwich on the way and planted a kiss on Adora’s cheek.

“Now I’m smelling it,” Adora said with a frown.

“Isn’t it heavenly?” Catra grinned and finished her milk. “Earth food has some great things going for it.”

“Earth food has a lot to answer for,” Glimmer grumbled.

“Catra was complaining about overeating after the British dinner,” Adora said.

Catra glared at her while Bow shook his head and Glimmer scoffed. That was classified information! She looked at the board. “So, how goes the planning?”

“Well, we still haven’t finished our presentation,” Adora said.

“There are several political issues to consider,” Glimmer explained. “And, as I told Adora, we can’t really plan for everything when we don’t even know the stances of our allies on the post of supreme commander.”

“It won’t hurt to plan ahead anyway,” Adora defended herself. “We need to make a good impression at the first alliance meeting.”

Catra snorted. “We’ve got the fleet. We can make any impression we want.”

Adora frowned at her, but Catra knew she was right. The power discrepancy was too big.

“That’s shortsighted,” Glimmer retorted. “If we act like a bully now, then Earth will remember it when they have caught up to us.”

“Right.” Catra nodded. “Long-term, it’s probably better not to tweak their noses too much.”

“We shouldn’t bully anyone anyway, regardless of future consequences,” Adora insisted. “It wouldn’t be right.”

Catra patted her shoulder. “And that’s why I think you would make a great supreme commander.”

Adora kept frowning at her. Glimmer tried not to frown, Catra noted. And Bow… stared at his tablet and tried not to draw attention.

Catra snorted and shook her head. “Sparkles, you would also work as a commander. Probably better than Adora, actually.” Glimmer blinked, and Adora looked surprised, but before either could say anything, Catra added: “As Supreme Commander, you’d be able to keep her from trying to do everything and blame herself for every setback or death.”

Glimmer laughed, Adora pouted - and Bow gave her a thumbs up.

“I’m not that bad!” Adora protested.

“Adora…” Bow trailed off.

“Yes. Yes, you are,” Glimmer said. “We still love you.”

Catra didn’t grab Adora’s arm in response. Glimmer didn’t mean it that way. “Yes,” she said instead, “We love you despite your faults.”

“I’m not that bad!” Adora repeated herself with that pout that always made Catra want to kiss her.

They weren’t in the bedroom, but you could hardly call this public. So she leaned in with a wide grin, and Adora’s eyes widened, and Catra reached out and planted a kiss on her lips.

But before she could really enjoy it, Glimmer sighed loudly. “This is a planning session, not a make-out session.”

“Spoilsport,” Catra whispered as Adora withdrew, blushing.

“Sorry, sorry,” her lover said. “It’s just…”

“It’s Catra’s fault, we know.” Glimmer nodded sagely.

“No! I mean… It’s not just Catra’s fault.”

That wasn’t exactly a staunch defence, but Catra didn’t mind. She shrugged and leaned against the seat closest to the board, and

when Glimmer and Bow looked back at the circles and columns on it, she mouthed ‘bedroom’ to Adora.

But Adora was, although still blushing, all professional now, standing at parade rest and staring at the board as well. Rats. “So… I think we have a good case here. And we won’t need to bully anyone.” She frowned at everyone else. “We need to set a good example - for everyone!”

“Yes,” Bow agreed. “The people on Earth already complain about us ‘forcing’ our views on them.”

“Stupid idiots!” Glimmer hissed. “We didn’t do anything like that.”

“We didn’t, no. And we won’t stoop to bullying our allies around,” Adora said. “Even if we think they deserve it or are being stupid. It’s not right.”

“Not even when it’d be funny?” Catra joked, flashing her fangs. But Adora frowned at her, and Glimmer glared. And Bow looked disappointed rather than amused. Well, can’t win them all.

“We need to set an example,” Adora said. “Our troops will look to us as role models. If we break our own rules, if we don’t do what’s right, they won’t either.”

That was straight out of cadet lessons about command and leadership. Not that it was wrong, of course. If Adora stepped out of line, Priest would take it as a sign and try to outdo her. On the other hand, sometimes, you needed to be a bit… pragmatic in war. Glimmer understood that. Adora… tried to ignore that. Even if it hurt her. Sometimes especially if it hurt her.

“We’ll be good,” Catra said with a wide smile.

Adora frowned some more at her, apparently not convinced - as if Catra would do anything to hurt her - but Glimmer and Bow nodded.

"And we'll keep our troops - and the Earth troops in line," Glimmer said.

"And we'll keep each other in line," Bow added.

That was a little… Catra blinked; Bow wasn't looking at her - he was looking at Glimmer, who barely managed to stop frowning. Oh.

Well, Bow wasn't wrong. And Glimmer loved him. But it was still brave of him to say it.

Catra reached over and patted Glimmer on the back. "Don't worry. We'll tell you when you're about to go overboard."

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at Catra. "I have no doubt that you'll tell me everything I did wrong - if I become Supreme Commander."

Catra chuckled.

But Adora started to nod before she realised what she was doing. "Well, only if it's a really big mistake," she said - a little too earnest for Glimmer's taste, Catra thought.

Well, that couldn't be helped. They were about to launch a war that was bigger than the war against the Horde or Horde Prime. They couldn't afford stupid mistakes. Or any mistakes.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 25th, 1998

"Well, that went better than I expected," Jack O'Neill said after they had left the meeting room - and had closed the door behind them, of course. Hammond knew him too well not to expect such a flippant comment, but one had to uphold appearances. Especially now, with foreigners in the mountain. "They didn't throw us into jail or demoted us."

“You expected them to jail us?” Daniel gasped.

Jack grinned at him. “Do you really think they would throw the best friends of our magical space princess alliance - our magical space princess alliance with which we want to be allied - into jail for telling the truth on television? That would sabotage all our efforts to make nice with them.”

Daniel closed his mouth and frowned at him for a moment. “Didn’t you say yesterday that the Russians and the Chinese would love that?”

Of course they’d love to see the USA excluded from the alliance with Etheria. The limeys and the French would probably like that as well. “But they can’t do it - we didn’t tell them any of the new secrets, just old ones - and those belong to the Air Force.”

“I thought we didn’t tell any secrets.”

“Not real secrets. Just open secrets.” Jack grinned. “Anyway - see you at dinner, team. I have to train our FNGs some more.” He waved and left before Daniel could find another argument. His friend would get over it. As would Carter.

And if things went as planned, they’d be back in the real action sooner than planned.

Jack had no wish to play security for foreign space tourists while his friends were fighting a war against the snakes. The upcoming trip to Cimmeria would show if Stargate Command could still do any real missions.

He shook his head as he entered the lift leading up - he had another batch of recruits to run ragged in the field.

Before the doors could close, someone else stepped inside, and Jack tensed.

“Lieutenant Lenkova. Cutting it a little close, are we?”

“Colonel O’Neill.” The spy frowned. “What do you mean?”

Jack made a point of checking his watch. “Training starts in ten minutes.”

“Yes?” She cocked her head to the side.

“It’s usually good form to be ready for training in the field before the officer in charge arrives,” he told her. “At least in the United States Armed Forces.”

“Yes?” That look of confused innocence had to be an act. “It’s the same in Russia.”

“And you’re currently riding an elevator with the officer in charge of the exercise.” Well, the training session - the FNGs weren’t yet ready for an actual exercise. But it sounded better than ‘basic training’.

“Yes?” she repeated herself for the third time.

“Which implies that we’ll arrive together.” He inclined his head.

Her expression changed into a grin. He would call it impish if that wouldn’t make him sound like he read romance novels. “It’s good to warm up before exercise, da?”

Jack narrowed his eyes at her. “You’re planning to run to the training area?”

“Extra exercise is a good thing, isn’t it?”

Was she checking him out - or implying that he needed the exercise as well? Challenge him to a race? Either way, Jack wouldn’t be falling for that. He knew he was in top shape - Adora’s healing had done wonders. And he wasn’t falling for a pretty blonde under his command. Certainly not for a Russian honey trap!

They reached the changeover floor - Stargate Command lacked lifts that went all the way up to the entrance level - and she was out of the cabin before the doors had fully opened. She was actually sprinting to the lift to the surface.

Jack grinned as he followed at a more leisurely pace. Well, the joke was on her - he knew the timing of the lifts, and so he knew he would…

She hit the button to close the doors on the way into the lift. They promptly closed.

…apparently have to wait for the next lift. Jack sighed and ignored the two guards next to the lift. The exercise wouldn't start without him, anyway.

But Jack was man enough to admit that this round went to the Lieutenant. He'd get her back during training.

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"Again, from the top!" Jack O'Neill yelled, channelling his inner drill sergeant. "That was almost acceptable - for raw recruits!"

The squad that had just 'run the gauntlet' groaned and grumbled as the soldiers trotted back to the starting point.

"I believe that they performed above the level of raw recruits, O'Neill."

Jack turned to look at Teal'c. "Well, yes, but you don't tell them that. Can't have them become complacent, can we?"

"Would they be suitable for Stargate Command if they are unable to judge their own performance objectively?"

"They know they aren't doing too badly," Jack explained. "But they also know they can do better." Much better, once they sorted out tactics and team roles and adapted to the exercise.

“Ah.” Teal’c nodded.

Both of them watched the next squad go through the exercise. They were Lenkova’s squad. And, to Jack’s slight annoyance, they were doing well. Covering each other was expected, but they also adjusted to the Goa’uld weapons - the simulated ones - well enough. Even the staggered staff weapon volleys didn’t keep them down.

And Lenkova was leading from the front. Usually, that could be grounds for criticism - officers weren’t supposed to take point since that would leave their men leaderless. On the other hand, sometimes, you had to run ahead because that was the only way to get them to follow you.

And Jack would be a hypocrite if he criticised her for things he regularly did in the field.

Still, it would be nice if she made a mistake he could point out. Just telling her to advance more smoothly and more quickly didn’t have the same ring to it.

But the damned Russian spy didn’t cooperate - her squad finished as the best so far. And the woman knew it as she saluted him. “Mission accomplished, Sir!” She wasn’t quite smiling, but he could tell that she was amused.

“We don’t salute in the field,” he told her with a nod. They were supposed to act as if they were in the field during the exercise. “Good work. Now make it faster.”

She returned the nod and this time, she smiled, then told her squad in Russian to grab more sim ammo and line up for another go.

Instead of joining them, she pulled out her canteen and took a swallow. “Anything else that needs to be improved, Sir?”

“Nothing critical,” he told her. “Teal’c?”

“You lead more aggressively than the Americans,” Jack’s friend said.

“It’s our doctrine.” She grinned. “We aren’t as averse to casualties as the Americans.”

‘Averse to casualties’? She must have watched American TV. Of course she would have watched it - she was a spy, after all.

“Yes. Like the Jaffa,” Teal’c said.

Even Jack couldn’t tell if that was meant as a compliment or not. Lenkova nodded, then went to rejoin her squad.

Jack watched her go, looking at how she moved in the Russian fatigues. He still thought the American ones were superior, but now they would be able to directly compare the two.

“She is a formidable warrior,” Teal’c commented.

“Without a doubt,” Jack agreed. And a dangerous spy - he caught her glancing over her shoulder back at him.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 25th, 1998

“We’re in space. That’s Earth below us.”

“What a sight!”

“It looks so small.”

“Not as small as from the moon.”

“Still…”

“Impressive.”

Adora smiled as she watched the three ministers from France, Germany and the United Kingdom, as well as their aides and

generals, look at the planet floating below them. It was a touching moment - and very symbolic, in her opinion.

"Who wants to bet that the whole 'your ship is a neutral place for the preliminary meeting favouring no one' was just an excuse so they could go to space?" Catra whispered behind her.

Trust her to assume the worst! Adora sighed as Glimmer giggled. Although she had to admit that their guests were very enthusiastic about space. Maybe they should hold their meeting with NASA's representatives - which they needed to schedule, she reminded herself - in space as well?

Still… they had a war to plan. Adora cleared her throat. "It's an impressive sight, yes," she said. "You can see the entire world from here."

"Or target it," Catra added.

That ruined the mood, and everyone grew serious.

"Yes, the information we received from the USA also showed how vulnerable Earth is to attacks from space," the British minister said.

"That's why we have a fleet here," Glimmer told him.

"But you're not planning to keep it in place until we've started building ships of our own, are you?"

"No," Glimmer said. "Based on our information, we don't need the entire fleet here - or on Etheria - to protect the planet. The Goa'uld are divided, which renders them vulnerable and also makes it harder for them to launch an offensive. Any System Lord who wants to attack Earth will have to expose their own holdings to attacks from their rivals in order to free the troops and ships for that."

"And even if they managed that, using Teal'c's information about Apophis's forces as a baseline for one of the most powerful

System Lords, they wouldn't be able to match our forces here," Catra added. "And that's not accounting for our technological superiority."

"So, we can spare the ships for offensive operations." Glimmer nodded.

"But the more worlds we take, the more ships are needed to defend them. This favours the attacker," the British admiral pointed out. "We need to hit their forces and destroy their offensive capability."

"And if they unite against us, the whole equation changes," the French general added. "And once they realise the threat we pose to them, they have a very compelling reason to unite."

"They have to realise that first," Glimmer retorted. "We will conceal our numbers and aims for as long as possible. And the Goa'uld still need to trust each other. We can counteract that by striking at select System Lords and leaving others - preferably their rivals - alone. That would sow distrust."

"If it works out. It's still a risky strategy." The German minister looked grim.

"It's less dangerous than staying in this system and hoping the Goa'uld ignore you," Catra retorted. "They will check on Earth, and that means we have to stop them, and then they'll know about us and our forces. It's better to hit them first."

"But they will attack Earth anyway once they realise Earth troops are taking their planets." The British minister tilted his head.

"That's why we need scouts and spies," Catra told him. "We need to track their forces."

Adora nodded. The spy bots Entrapta and Sam were building would help there. But they didn't have actual spies. Well, they could send Double Trouble, but Glimmer and Catra didn't trust

them. The Tok'Ra were an option, but not even SG-1 had any idea how to contact them.

"That will be a challenge given the sheer size of the Goa'uld Empire." The French General nodded at the map of the galaxy floating in the middle of the room.

"Yes. But it's a challenge we can overcome." Adora did her best to sound confident. Entrapta had mentioned plans to build self-replicating spy bots or something. That should help.

"I hope so." But the British admiral didn't sound very hopeful, not to Adora at least.

"In any case, we need to first set the structure of the Alliance." Adora leaned forward. That was the point of this meeting, after all. Well, one of the points - she would love to use her presentation, but they were saving that for the main meeting. "We need a chain of command, clear duties, and a structure that will allow us to integrate more members." Such as other, smaller European countries, and the United States, if they managed to stop their bigotry.

The delegations tensed up. "Yes. A chain of command is essential for any military force," the German minister said. "Though who sets the policies that the military is tasked to enact? We cannot simply act according to purely military concerns, or we risk overly focusing on such matters."

Adora frowned. What did he mean?

"The goals of the war will be set by the rulers of the countries involved," Glimmer said.

Adora nodded.

"And what if the rulers are also personally involved in fighting in the war?" the German asked. "Etheria has a tradition of the rulers of states also personally leading the troops, hasn't it?"

Adora blinked. Why would that matter?

Glimmer looked surprised as well. “Yes.”

“That would give them significant influence on both policies and military decisions as well as information on both,” the French minister said. “This can be problematic.”

“I would think that’s an advantage for everyone,” Adora said. “Less friction and possible misunderstanding between those who make the policies and those who execute them.”

That sounded logical to her - and to her friends, who were nodding - but it was obvious that the Europeans didn’t quite agree.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 25th, 1998

“...and that is why a mission to return to Cimmeria should be undertaken,” Samantha Carter finished. She didn’t show her annoyance at having to give an entirely superfluous presentation when she nodded at the five generals facing her. Even if you discounted the need to further investigate the mystery of the creator’s of Thor’s Hammer or the moral need to check on how the planet fared without its protections - something Sam had to admit Stargate Command should have done much, much sooner - it was also obvious that refusing permission would antagonise the Etherians.

And why would anyone want to do that? The Colonel had speculated that some countries might want to show that they didn’t bow to the Etherians, but Sam didn’t think that any of the permanent members of the Security Council would be amongst those - not when they were either in an alliance with the Etherians or courting their favour. A powerplay was also not very likely since the Etherians could probably just claim the spare Stargate they had found on the way to Earth. Sam had no doubt

that Entrapta could rig up a computer to use it. Russia or China might want to play to their populations, but Sam doubted that they would be willing to leak secrets like Cimmeria to the public.

And yet, the command committee was acting as if approving this mission was somehow controversial and had to be deliberated carefully.

"We've read the files on the last - and only - mission to that planet," General Li said. "Two members of your team almost died, and you had to destroy a planetary defence system of unknown origin to save them."

"Yes, Sir." Sam had just explained that.

"Your actions could be very well seen as hostile to the population of Cimmeria - or their protectors," Li went on.

"Yes. That is why we need to find out who created the defence system so we can explain our actions, should that be needed." Sam also had said that already.

"And what if that fails?" Li didn't frown, but his tone carried the same meaning. "Wars have been started over less. What if you open a new front with an unknown galactic power? A power with more advanced technology than the Goa'uld."

"That's why we should meet them and explain what happened," Sam said. She wished that the Colonel was here instead of training the soldiers. On the other hand, after his stunt with Daniel, it was probably better that he wasn't here. General Hammond might have arranged this deliberately.

"They would have to tie this to Earth, first. And then they would have to find us," General Haig cut in.

"The Cimmerians know that we're from Earth," Sam retorted.

"The Cimmerians know that you claimed this," General Sidorov said. "But would the unknown party believe that? Or would they

assume that this was a covert operation by a Goa'uld hoping to divert retaliation? You had a Jaffa with you and disabled the defence system. This does look rather suspicious."

The Colonel's comments about paranoid Russians might have some merit, Sam thought. "This seems rather reaching, Sir," she said with a very polite expression.

He glared at her anyway.

"I think the mere possibility that we might have antagonised another galactic power is grounds enough to investigate the planet," General Haig said. General Petit and General Hammond nodded, so that meant the majority was in favour of the mission. Sam started to smile when the General went on: "Although I think it might be better not to send the same team that created said incident in the first place. The system did detect a Jaffa, didn't it? And according to your file, you still have enhanced levels of Naquadah in your blood, Captain Carter. You could be mistaken for a Goa'uld host."

Sam clenched her teeth at the reminder of her time as a host. As much as it stung - and felt insulting - that the General thought she should be excluded, she couldn't refute the reasons offered.

"Yes," General Petit agreed with his British colleague. "I think a new team would be a better choice. Together with whoever the Etherians send, they should have less trouble convincing whoever built the defence system that it was a mistake, not an act of sabotage that destroyed it."

"SG-1 is our most experienced team," General Hammond pointed out. "And they have been working with the Etherians before."

"No one doubts that. But we cannot rely on a single team," General Li said. "We need more teams with experience and who are used to working with the Etherians."

Sam couldn't fault the logic here, either - but it also felt like a political move. And an attempt to squeeze SG-1 out.

"Captain Carter is also our foremost expert on alien technology," Hammond retorted.

"Another reason not to send her into high-risk situations," General Haig said.

Sam clenched her teeth again. She was an officer in the Air Force, and she had probably more combat experience than most of the generals in the room. But as a captain, you didn't snap at generals.

"The Etherians might not want to work with an unknown team instead of their friends," General Hammond argued.

"I am sure they'll understand our reasoning," General Sidorov told him.

Sam wasn't so sure. But she held her tongue.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 25th, 1998

"Congratulations, Supreme Commander Adora," Catra said as she handed Adora a glass.

"I'm not Supreme Commander. This was just a preliminary discussion. Nothing is set in stone." Adora shook her head.

Catra smiled wrily.

"They were pretty insistent," Glimmer said. "I don't think they'll budge on that. They don't want a ruling princess as Supreme Commander. Because they fear corruption." She frowned.

Bow patted her back, then slung his arm around her waist and pulled her to his side. "They don't know you. You'd never abuse the position to favour Bright Moon."

Catra agreed - but also because the war would be fought in space and on other planets. There was no reason nor any real way to favour Bright Moon by strengthening its defences and letting other kingdoms get conquered. She wasn't entirely sure what Glimmer would do if she had to decide whether Bright Moon or Salineas would be defended.

Glimmer didn't look mollified, even though she leaned into Bow's side. "It's just so stupid."

"Yes!" Adora nodded. "Whether or not you rule shouldn't be a reason to deny you a post."

Catra hesitated a moment, then made a humming sound. "Well, you could claim that if you have to rule a kingdom, you can't focus entirely on fighting a war - especially away from your kingdom."

"I've got Dad for that," Glimmer said with a pout.

Catra shrugged. She agreed with the others that their new allies just didn't want too much power concentrated in one person. Which was… well, it was inefficient. On the other hand, Earth was full of stories of the military taking over a country. That's what happened if you didn't have princesses. Or, she reminded herself, if you had technological superiority. Hordak had taken over the Scorpion Kingdom in a similar way, after all. "Anyway, so Adora's set as the Supreme Commander. They think they've won, but it won't really change things."

Adora nodded. "And we can tell them that!"

Catra sighed and looked at Glimmer and Bow. Bow looked away.

Glimmer set her jaw. "No, Adora. We can't tell them that. We can't undermine your command from the start. If they don't want a ruling princess, they'll get She-Ra. But you can't act as if you're just doing my bidding."

Adora opened her mouth, but Catra was quicker: "And we know you wouldn't actually just do what Sparkles said. But when you

act as if it doesn't matter whether you or Glimmer are in command, they'll assume the worst." She shrugged. "They'll see how the Alliance runs things soon enough." With lots of talking and discussing until a decision was made.

"I think they run their alliances the same as we do, actually," Bow said. "That's why they want Adora."

Catra snorted. "They underestimate you."

"What?" Adora frowned again.

"They probably think you're a bit naive - inexperienced in politics," Glimmer said.

"I am inexperienced in politics," Adora told them. "But I'm not naive. Right?"

"You are a little naive," Catra told her. "And we love you for it." She knew it very well - anyone other than Adora would have given up on her years ago.

"I think you made a good impression, Adora. They trust you to be completely honest with them." Bow beamed at her.

Catra took a step closer to Adora. Bow had his own princess to handle.

"And they don't trust me," Glimmer complained.

"Well, we already knew that they have issues with princesses - ruling princesses," Bow said. "They have their own system."

Not a very bright system, in Catra's opinion. You could see that when you looked at the trouble the Americans had with changing their policies. On the other hand, if Hordak had lost his position after an election, that would've been funny. She snorted.

"What's so funny?" Glimmer glared at her.

And Adora was frowning again.

“I just imagined a democratic Horde, with Hordak losing an election,” Catra explained.

Adora giggled. “Could you imagine his reaction?”

Glimmer and Bow were a bit more restrained.

“Anyway, I think you’re set for Supreme Commander, Adora. No getting out of this.” Catra grinned and took a sip from her drink.

Adora sighed once more and took a swallow from her own. Then she gasped and stared at the glass? “What’s this?”

“White Russian.” Catra grinned, showing her teeth. “Vodka and cream!” And some other stuff, but that was optional in her opinion.

Glimmer made some gagging noise even though Catra hadn’t offered her one.

And Adora frowned. “What’s vodka?”

“Strong booze from Russia,” Catra told her.

“We shouldn’t drink when we’re in a planning session.”

“We had a planning session. We’re relaxing now,” Catra corrected her.

“I can’t relax if I might become Supreme Commander!”

“That’s what the drink is for!” Catra raised her own and took another sip.

“Catra!”

Catra grinned. Adora was so cute when she got mad over nothing. “Drink your White Russian and relax.” She was pretty sure Adora would, too.

Her lover was still holding the glass, after all.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 26th, 1998

"So, instead of sending us, they'll send a new team without any experience?" Jack O'Neill didn't bother hiding what he thought of that plan.

"The majority of my colleagues feel that the presence of SG-1 could be misunderstood by whoever built the defence system that you destroyed," General Hammond replied. "Especially in the case of Teal'c and Captain Carter."

Who could be mistaken as a Goa'uld and their Jaffa. Jack frowned. It wasn't a bad point. It was a good point, actually - at least in this particular situation, where the defence system had already mistakenly identified Teal'c as an enemy. But he hated admitting anything like that - he had a reputation to maintain. And Carter didn't look like she agreed, and Jack wouldn't stab her in the back. "Are they going to disguise the team as well? That'll do wonders for building trust."

Daniel snorted, Jack noticed. Hammond, though, wasn't amused. "The consensus was that our Etherian friends wouldn't take well to that kind of deception."

Translation: It was actually proposed, but people wised up and used the Etherians as a face-saving excuse. At least Jack hoped that this was the case - if the only reason they hadn't gone with disguises was that the magical space princesses might not like it, then things were worse than he had feared. "And how have the Etherians taken the news that they'll go to Cimmeria with a bunch of unknown FNGs?"

"Stargate Command will be sending a veteran team." Hammond slightly frowned at him.

“Oh, great. Strangers then. I bet they’re thrilled.” Jack shook his head.

“The Etherians have yet to be informed about the details of the mission.” Hammond didn’t like it either, Jack could tell, even though the general’s expression remained neutral.

“They won’t like that even less,” Jack said.

“Yes,” Daniel chimed in. “As far as I understood, they expect to head out there with us - SG-1. Now, the concerns about possible misunderstandings shouldn’t be dismissed easily, but I think they would expect to be allowed to have a say in this before a decision was made.”

“And wouldn’t that be a shame if they demanded changes to the mission!” Jack watched Hammond’s reaction to his comment.

The general frowned. “Stargate Command isn’t in the habit of letting its teams use their relationship with foreign powers to get their way and overrule their commanding officer.”

So, Hammond wouldn’t look away if Jack had a frank talk with the Etherians.

“But the Etherians will want to talk to us. Do you expect us to refuse a meeting with them? Or to lie?” Daniel asked.

“I expect you to act with the loyalty and integrity expected from a member of Stargate Command,” Hammond replied. “If the Security Council gets the impression that the Etherians have undue influence on Stargate Command, and that individual members are trying to exploit that to control which teams are assigned to any missions, then the whole agreement will be revisited.”

Jack wouldn’t mind that. But Hammond would. And it would be bad for the entire Stargate Command - well, at least for the part Jack cared about. So he nodded. “Yes, Sir.”

Hammond stared at him for a moment, and Jack did his best to look honest. He wasn't about to stab the general in the back either. And he would make sure that his team would follow his lead.

But he had a bad feeling about this mission now.

*****

Cimmeria Part 2

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 26th, 1998

"We're not going with you?" Adora blinked.

Jack shrugged. "It's been deemed too dangerous because we kind of wrecked their defence system when we visited - we had an excellent reason, of course, so don't feel bad, Carter - and so those who built it might think we're their enemies, what with them having mistaken us for Goa'uld once already. So… it was decided that another team should head there with you."

Adora frowned. That sounded… well, it made sense, but still. It didn't feel right.

"So, will the new guys dress up or wear the same uniforms you wore when you wrecked the defence system?" Catra asked. "It's not exactly hard to tell that you come from the same planet if you wear the same uniform."

Adora nodded. That was the point of uniforms, after all.

"Well… that hasn't been decided yet," Jack said.

"Trying to hide your planet of origin isn't good for building trust," Bow pointed out with a frown. "If you plan to reveal the truth at a later date."

"Or if they find out before you reveal the truth," Catra added.

Once more, Adora nodded. "It doesn't seem to be very honest to use fake uniforms."

"You wore Horde uniforms as well to infiltrate a base, remember?" Catra asked.

Adora pouted. “That was a legitimate tactic against the Horde. But we’re not going there to fight the Cimmerians or their protectors. We aren’t at war with them.”

“Well, at least as far as we know,” Jack said. “They might have a different opinion.”

“You could be at war and don’t know it,” Glimmer said. “Sounds familiar.”

Jack frowned at her while Catra grinned. “Good one, Sparkles!”

“But… if you’re not coming, how can we do science together?” Entrapta asked Sam with a deep pout. “Hordak and I did some work on remote-controlled lab assistants, but they aren’t meant to be used through a gate or in the field - well, we could modify them.”

Sam looked uncomfortable. “I will be in my lab, ready to support you if you need help. Remotely.”

“Or… What if we go through the gate and look around, and if there’s no shooting war going on, we call you in?” Adora suggested.

“Well, the mission is basically checking if we started a war,” Jack replied. “Coming in afterwards is more like a tourist trip.”

“Jack!” Daniel frowned at him. “We would talk to the Cimmerians, learn more about their culture and history and see if we can analyse the technology. Check for more clues about its creators. We wouldn’t be tourists.”

“Active tourists then.” Jack shrugged again. “Anyway, SG-2 is supposed to go with you on the mission, But we’ll be ready to assist you. And not just remotely,” he added.

“Good! We need your assistance!” Entrapta beamed at Sam.

Jack coughed. “That’s not how that works,” he said, glancing at Adora.

“So, we can’t call on you for assistance?” Catra cocked her head with a toothy grin. “Sounds like we’d be under your command then…”

Jack glared at her. “You know what I mean. Playing such games doesn’t make you popular with the brass.”

The brass? Ah, the generals. Adora frowned. “But deciding that we should go with SG-2 instead of you without even asking us wasn’t really friendly either.”

Jack looked a little uncomfortable. “Well, the generals in command of Stargate Command get to decide what team they send on a mission. Generally.”

That sounded a bit like…

“What do you think of this?” Glimmer asked with narrowed eyes.

Jack sighed. “Well, I want to go, and I think SG-1 could do the job. But I understand and accept the concerns that the generals have. About the whole thing. We did kind of wreck stuff, and people tend to take that badly. Whether it’s someone’s lawnmower or someone’s planetary defence system.”

“Wait - did you wreck your neighbour’s lawnmower, Jack?” Daniel asked.

“No, I didn’t.” Jack smiled. “And you can’t prove anything!”

Catra chuckled, and Adora snorted almost against her will. “So, you are alright with this?”

“I just said that, didn’t I?” Jack tilted his head a little.

Catra snorted again.

“But that’s still unfair! I wanted to work with Sam!” Entrapta protested.

“There’ll be other missions,” Sam told her.

“And who knows - maybe things go wrong, and we have to charge in to help fix it and save the planet,” Jack added.

Adora pressed her lips together as she remembered the Heart of Etheria. And what she had to do to save it. “Let’s not hope for that, please.”

“Yes,” Daniel agreed. “I would love for a mission that goes without a hitch.”

“Well, what are the odds that this will end up with us learning that the mysterious creators haven’t returned, as they hadn’t for a long, long time?” Jack grinned. “It might be a milk run.”

“Do you really think that, Jack?” Adora asked.

“Well… we can hope? Our track record isn’t looking promising, though,” Jack replied.

“That’s mostly SG-1. Other teams didn’t have so many, uh, interesting missions as we had,” Daniel said.

“That’s because we usually get the most difficult and important missions.”

“Like this one?” Glimmer asked with a wry smile.

Jack nodded. “Exactly. So, we good?”

Adora looked at her friends. Entrapta was still pouting, Hordak was stoic or something, but the others nodded. “Let’s go meet SG-2, then,” she said.

“And the generals,” Catra added. “Can’t forget them.”

“Yes, we really must talk to them,” Glimmer added.

Jack grinned.

*****

“I really wish you could come with us.” Entrapta pouted again. The third time in about as many minutes.

Not that Samantha Carter was counting. She shrugged and suppressed a sigh. “I would like to come as well, but the reasoning by my superiors is sound. My presence could ruin our chances to avoid another conflict.”

“If your absence alone would make the difference between war and peace, then I think those people who created the defence system you sabotaged would probably find another reason to start a war,” Entrapta retorted. “They sound like easily provoked.”

“We actually don’t know if they even noticed what happened,” Sam explained. “They might have abandoned Cimmeria - or they might be gone extinct. We’re just playing things as safe as possible until we know more.”

“Ah.” Entrapta frowned. “But being too cautious can be dangerous as well. Catra explained that to me once.”

“I believe that was about operations during the war,” Hordak cut in. “Not about opening lines of communications to an unknown force.”

Sam nodded. “When approaching unknown people, it’s best to err on the side of caution.”

“Unless you need a show of strength to impress them,” Hordak added.

“That could be seen as a hostile approach,” Sam pointed out.

“And if hostilities broke out afterwards, you would have given away crucial data about your capabilities.” Hordak nodded. Of course the former warlord would think of that!

“Couldn’t you avoid that by making sure your demonstration is safe?” Entrapta cocked her head as her hair fiddled with some of Sam’s tools.

“We would have to know more about the others to judge what’s considered safe,” Sam said, quoting Daniel. “Making first contact is a very delicate affair, generally.”

“Well, when we met you, things worked out well!” Entrapta nodded.

Sam suppressed a wince. They had almost shot at Melog when SG-1 had met the Etherians for the first time. It wasn’t a good example of a peaceful first contact. “Well, if SG-2 and you give the clear, we can follow you,” she said.

“Alright!” Entrapta beamed, and her hair picked up more tools. “So, what are you working on today? Did you look into our remote-controlled bot idea?”

“Yes,” Sam replied. “We need a safe connection, though. And while I think it would be safe enough for remote lab work in space, I don’t think we should rely on it for dangerous work in inhabited areas.” If she made a mistake due to lag or loss of connection while manipulating Naquadah-enhanced gear…

“It would still be safer for defusing bombs than doing it in person,” Hordak said. “I believe you already use robots for that.”

“Poor things!” Entrapta exclaimed. “They risk getting blown up!”

That was their purpose. “Most of them can’t act autonomously,” Sam told her. “They aren’t sapient. Or sentient.”

“Like most of our bots,” Hordak added. “Even though they can act autonomously.”

“But some bots are sapient! And if we give them enough time and unlock their neural matrixes to evolve in response to stimuli, most of our advanced bots can develop sentience, then sapience,”

Entrapta retorted. “That’s why we need remote-controlled bots - so everyone’s safe from getting blown up!”

“We use remote-controlled Mobile Analytic Laboratory Probes - M.A.L.P.s - but they aren’t as mobile as your bots,” Sam said. Although she thought they had more options for scanning. On the other hand, she hadn’t thoroughly analysed the spybots of the Etherians.

“Well, that can be fixed!” Entrapta nodded several times. “And if we’re lucky, we can investigate the technology on Cimmeria ourselves. It might be First Ones in origin.”

Sam nodded. Although given SG-1’s luck, she wasn’t very optimistic. On the other hand. SG-2 might have better luck.

“Oh! Did I show you the plans for self-replicating exploration bots yet?” Entrapta said, putting down another set of tools.

Sam blinked. “Self-replicating exploration bots?”

“Or spybots, yes. We need as many spybots as possible to spy on the Goa’uld, right? So, I thought about ways to achieve that. And self-replicating bots are the answer! The initial development cost is higher, but once they get going, they can increase their numbers exponentially once they find enough resources. We should have coverage of most of the Goa’uld-controlled systems in no time!”

“You want to create Von Neumann probes?” Sam had a sinking feeling in her gut.

“Oh! You already have a model? Can I see it?”

Sam winced at Entrapta’s enthusiasm.

“I think releasing self-replicating bots has to be considered very carefully,” she said. “What if they get out of control? Even if they only continue to replicate, they would soon require enormous amounts of resources.” That was what exponential growth did.

“Well, they would be hardened against the First Ones tech virus,” Entrapta replied. “Although you are correct that they also need a limit. Although checking if such a limit was reached would require them to be in constant contact with each other. That might influence their stealth capability. On the other hand, it would greatly enhance cooperation between bots, should that be required. And whatever one bot experienced would be available - although not as a direct neural copy - to every other bot.”

Not just a Von Neumann probe - a hive mind. Sam felt a cold shiver run down her spine. “If the spy bots can learn, that means they can adapt. And that means they could evolve.”

“Yes!” Entratpa nodded with a smile.

“What if they evolved out of your control?” Provided Entrapta was planning to control them in the first place.

“Well, if they develop sapience - and I think they would - controlling them without their consent would be wrong, wouldn’t it?” Entrapta tilted her head.

Sam closed her eyes. It was as she had feared. “And what if they start behaving like, ah, Priest? Or see everyone else as competition for resources? Or as enemies?”

“Those are good points. We should limit their neural network,” Hordak said, nodding.

“But that would mean they can’t ever develop sapience!”

That was the point! “I think if you want sapient bots, they shouldn’t be self-replicating,” Sam said.

“But everyone else is! People self-replicate! We don’t limit them like that!” Entrapta protested.

“But people don’t self-replicate exponentially,” Sam retorted. Well, not infinitely. Although that might be a reaction to resources as often as a result of cultural adaptation. “And releasing self-

replicating bots without limits would impact everyone else. Bots would grow at the expense of others. Would that be fair?”

Entrapta pouted but slowly nodded.

Sam suppressed a relieved sigh. One crisis averted before the mission had even started.

*****

“...and while we understand that it is your prerogative to decide which team you send on a specific mission, this is a joint mission,” Glimmer said. If she were standing instead of sitting at a conference table, she would have had her hands on her hips. Catra was sure of that. “We should’ve been consulted. Not just because this decision affects us and our dispositions as well, but we might have information that affects your decision.”

Catra watched the generals’ reaction. Hammond kept his expression politely interested and nodded once. The French general did the same, but his smile looked less honest - or so she thought. The British general frowned a little. The Russian frowned a lot, and the Chinese one didn’t show any reaction at all. Which was a reaction by itself, of course.

Well, she should have expected them to be good at the game - one advantage of being older. Probably.

“We are now discussing the mission,” the Chinese general said.

“After SG-1 told us about the change of teams,” Glimmer retorted. “Is that how things are done here?”

“You are friends with SG-1, aren’t you?” the Russian general said.

“Yes. But that doesn’t affect the chain of command,” Glimmer told him.

Well, it did, of course - in a pinch, Catra would be first listening to those she trusted no matter their ranks. And she was sure her

friends would do the same. But this wasn't about the chain of command but appearances. Or posturing. It was a power play.

"You know, we didn't have to play such games in the Horde," she whispered. You knew your place there.

"The Horde was all about such games," Adora whispered back. "Shadow Weaver did it all the time. And that worked out so well."

Right. Catra pressed her lips together as she remembered that Shadow Weaver had played such mind games all the time. It wasn't a happy memory. She frowned at her lover anyway.

"...and so we need to discuss such information on the level where such decisions are made," Glimmer said.

"Well, do you disagree with our reasoning?" the British general asked.

"In part," Adora spoke up. "We don't even know if the mysterious people who built the system you destroyed are on the planet. If we don't find them, there's no reason for SG-1 not to join us."

"Just because you don't see them doesn't mean they aren't watching from afar," the Russian general retorted.

"If you don't trust us to do recon, you shouldn't send us in the first place," Adora told him.

Catra nodded. This wasn't like in the Horde, where you often only found the Alliance forces when they attacked the Horde scouts. Or, at least, it shouldn't be. "That guy's paranoid," she whispered.

She didn't think the Russian had heard her, but he was frowning at her. Well, he seemed the type to expect the worst when someone whispered in his presence.

Catra smiled sweetly at him.

"We cannot afford another war with an interstellar power," Hammond said. "So, we have to proceed with caution here."

"Does that mean that even if we don't find any sign of those people, SG-1 will have to remain here?" Adora asked.

The generals exchanged some glances. "That will be decided once we have a clearer picture of the situation on Cimmeria," the British general told her.

"And what if we decide that we need their expertise?" Catra asked.

More glances and frowning followed. "The mission's success, of course, takes priority," Hammond replied.

Which neatly avoided answering if they would overrule Catra's friends.

This mission was off to a good start.

*****

For Jack O'Neill, watching the preparations in the gate room for a mission for another team was always a little… disturbing wasn't quite correct, but it came close. He wasn't arrogant - well, not very much - but SG-1 was the best team in Stargate Command. They had proven that repeatedly. The other teams weren't bad - Hell, they were amongst the best Jack knew when it came to special ops - but there were situations out there that SG-1 could handle and the other teams couldn't. Not really because of Jack, of course, but because when push came to shove, no scientist attached to Stargate Command could hold a candle to Carter, no one was as good as Daniel at getting aliens to talk instead of shooting at you, and Teal'c was the most dangerous man - alien - Jack had met. Well, before he met the Etherians.

Of course, the Etherians kind of changed the situation. The scientist assigned to SG-2, Willard, wasn't a genius, but Entrapta most certainly was. She was also a real-life mad scientist, though

that wasn't necessarily a bad thing on some missions. And Adora had some of the same earnest charm Daniel had in spades. Not to mention that Bow had a knack for technology as well.

He turned away from the M.A.L.P. being prepared for the mission to face the approaching Ferretti.

"Colonel." Ferretti greeted him a tad warily.

That was only natural - Jack knew how it felt when your superior was watching you work. Though Jack wouldn't show it quite as openly. Ferretti had been on the first mission to Abydos, but he still was a little… not green, but not on Jack's level. And he wasn't used to the Etherians. "Major. All set up for our diplomatic probe? Don't worry, the Etherians won't bite you. Probably not - Catra can get a little moody."

Ferretti's chuckle was a typical 'laugh at your superior's joke' thing. He must be more nervous than Jack had assumed. Then again, Catra was a prickly woman. "If in doubt, treat her like a cat," he added.

"Sir?" Ferretti cocked his head.

"You know, don't look like a mouse, don't tease her and stay out of the range of her claws." Jack grinned.

Ferretti laughed again, still a bit forced. "Yes, Sir. Any other advice?"

"Anything not in the briefing?" Jack struck a thinking pose. Daniel had been thorough. "If in doubt, trust them. Don't lie to them. And don't treat them like kids."

"Of course not, Sir." Ferretti nodded.

Jack refrained from frowning. "I mean it. I know they don't look it, but they've been through a war - they've grown up in a war and ended it. Personally. Don't try to treat them as you'd Willard, don't

try to protect them. If the shit hits the fan, let them take the lead and don't get in their way."

"I've talked to Major Warren, Sir."

Jack expected that. SG-3 would have spread the news about the Etherians after the fight with Seth. But it always paid to make sure. "Good." It still wasn't ideal, of course. SG-1 had spent far more time with the Etherians. Had gone on several missions with them, on Earth and in space. They should be here, ready to go to Cimmeria. But if wishes were horses, beggars would ride, as Daniel would say. He smiled. "So, any further questions?"

Ferretti didn't ask the one Jack was sure he wanted to ask - 'are you going to stop hovering over us here, Sir?' - but shook his head. "No, Sir."

"Good luck, then."

"Thank you, Sir." Ferretti turned away and went back to checking his and his team's gear.

And Jack was back to waiting for someone else to risk their life in his place.

"Jack!"

He turned again. That had been Adora - the Etherians had arrived. "Finished discussing our decision process with the brass?"

Adora blinked, then nodded. "Yes."

"Not that we have a result to show for," Catra added. The woman stretched her arms over her head, fingers entwined, and Jack saw one of the gate guards stare. The kid wasn't used yet to aliens.

"We didn't even get permission to call on you if we need you," Adora said.

Well, that would have given the Etherians the power to dictate who got to come on the mission - the generals wouldn't allow themselves to be outmanoeuvred like that. Even Hammond wouldn't let that fly. "Let's hope you don't need us," Jack told her. "Just a simple, boring mission that shows that nothing changed."

Catra snorted. "Yeah, right."

Adora pouted. "It could very well be like that."

"With our luck?" Catra raised her eyebrows, and her tail twitched.

"Whatever awaits us, we'll deal with it," Glimmer stated.

"That's the spirit!" Jack grinned.

"I still think you should come with us," Entrapta said. "It isn't fair that… Oh! There's the bot!" And she was off, headed for the M.A.L.P.

Jack hoped she wouldn't try to dismantle it. The things were expensive, as Stargate Command's budget could attest to. On the other hand, Entrapta could probably improve the things.

He blinked. On second thought, he'd better make sure she didn't tinker with it.

After introducing the Etherians to Ferretti and his team, of course.

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"Folks, this is Major Ferretti. Major - Adora, Princess of Power, Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, Princess Entrapta of Dryl who has deigned to join us again, Bow, Catra and Hordak."

Major Ferretti wasn't Jack. Adora knew it was unfair to compare the two - it wasn't Ferretti's decision to replace SG-1, and he seemed a skilled, competent soldier - but she would have preferred to do this mission with Jack and the others, not with people she didn't know and had never worked with. That wasn't a

good idea; even basic Horde command lessons taught you that. On the other hand, making new friends and allies was a good thing as well. “Hello, Major,” she said with a smile.

“Hello.” He nodded. He didn’t look nervous, which was… well, it should be a good sign. Of Confidence. Hopefully, not overconfidence.

The others greeted him as well - Catra with a ‘Yo’ - and he waved the rest of SG-2 over. “These are Lieutenants Casey and Bell and Dr Willard.”

Casey and Bell were soldiers like Ferretti. Willard looked more like Daniel. And all were nervous - Willard obviously so.

“Oh! Are you a scientist or a medical doctor?” Entrapta beamed at him.

“Ah… A physicist. Mainly.”

“Oh! So, what do you think we’ll encounter? Did you work with a lot of Goa’uld or Ancient technology before? Do you think the defence system is an entirely new technology? What do you think about bots?”

Quite reasonable questions, in Adora’s opinion. Although Entrapta should give the man more time to answer - he was gaping at her. And at her hair.

“So, you’re the FNGs Jack told us about?” Catra commented with a grin.

Adora suppressed a sigh. That was the wrong thing to say. Of course Catra would say it. Even though she knew better - she had gone through the same lessons as Adora, after all.

“No, SG-2 is an experienced Stargate Command team,” Jack corrected her with a frown. “We wouldn’t let FNGs through the gate.”

“But you’re not used to, well, us,” Bow spoke up.

“That won’t affect our performance,” Ferretti said.

“It better not,” Catra said.

“Maybe we should delay the mission until we know each other a bit better,” Adora suggested.

“We’ve done missions like this before.” And now Ferretti looked annoyed. As did Casey and Bell.

“Yep.” Jack nodded.

“Sorry.” Adora had just wanted to help. Well, if they were trained to fight like Jack, they could handle this - if it came to a fight. But she didn’t expect much from the team.

“We were just told that we’d be working with you,” Bow added. “We expected to go with SG-1.”

Their friends. Adora nodded. She understood the reasons the generals had given, but she didn’t like them. It was always better to go on such missions with people you knew and trusted, not unknowns. Even in the Horde, which had standardised training, you tended to keep squads together.

“Not your fault,” Catra said with a shrug. “But we’ve worked with SG-1 before.”

“Well, we’ll do our best to replace them,” Ferretti said.

They’d better.

After a moment of everyone staring at each other without saying anything, Jack clapped his hands. “So, let’s walk over and see what the M.A.L.P. can do? Provided that Entrapta didn’t take it apart.”

“I didn’t do anything to it!” Entrapta protested. “Although if you give me a bit of time, I could modify it… legs would make it more manoeuvrable, I think. And maybe add a gun so it can defend itself. And a neural matrix so it can act on its own.”

“I don’t think we want M.A.L.P.s that can think and shoot on their own,” Jack said.

“Why not?” Entrapta frowned.

“We don’t have the paperwork for it. And people get nervous about a robot revolution.” Jack shrugged.

“A robot revolution?” Adora asked. She remembered Entrapta’s bots going out of control due to the First One’s virus. That would be bad in here.

“It’s from a movie,” Jack replied.

“Ah.”

“They wouldn’t revolt. Unless you treat them badly,” Entrapta said. “And why would anyone treat a bot badly?”

“Military necessity,” Catra told her. “Sometimes, you have to send forces to their death.”

Entrapta pouted. “There’s no need to send sapient bots out to die.”

“Exactly. And M.A.L.P.s often get sent to dangerous, deadly worlds, so we don’t want them to be sapient,” Jack explained. “It’s kind of their job to be expendable.”

“Oh.” Entrapta looked surprised. “I guess that is a good reason not to give them neural matrixes.”

“Yeah.”

They were in front of the Stargate's ramp now - behind the bot. Or M.A.L.P. Whatever. Two techs were going over it, mumbling something about mad scientists. It seemed Entrapta had done more than just look it over.

Well, it was still in one piece and didn't sprout legs, so Adora doubted that any harm had been done.

While the M.A.L.P. was readied, they ran through communication checks and general gear checks. But, after ten more minutes, they were finally ready, and the Stargate was activated.

"Oh!" Entrapta beamed as it spun, and someone announced each chevron getting encoded and locked. "It looks even better than on recordings."

"I think security on this side is a bit light," Catra commented. "I'd have heavy weapons ready, not just a squad or two of infantry."

She was correct - the number of soldiers visible was a little low. "Perhaps there are hidden gun emplacements," Adora speculated.

"Or poison gas canisters?"

"We've got explosives in the ground as a last resort," Jack said. "But it's pretty hard to fight your way out of the gate room to the surface."

That was true. But if you just wanted to wreck the gate controls…

The wormhole formed, interrupting her thoughts. So, that was what the deadly energy Sam had mentioned looked like from up close - Adora could feel the hairs on her arms rise.

Then the M.A.L.P. started rolling up the ramp, entered the wormhole and vanished.

"It's through," Sam announced from behind. "Signal's… established."

“That is new,” Daniel commented, staring at the screen showing the M.A.L.P.’s feed. “That wasn’t there back when we visited.”

Adora turned and went to join them. Catra beat her to the screen by jumping over the console, startling Daniel. “Right. That’s not the Thor’s Hammer you described. Unless you hallucinated a lot when you saw it.”

Adora suppressed a frown as she rounded the console. Then she could finally see what the others were commenting on. And she blinked. “They walled off the gate area?”

“Those aren’t walls,” Jack said. “I bet those are weapon emplacements.”

“Weapon emplacements?” Adora looked for laser emitters or barrels but couldn’t see any. It looked like those were simple stone walls.

“Ah!” Catra nodded. “You think they covered the entire gate area in an anti-Goa’uld field?”

“Yes.” Jack grinned. “And that means that the Asgard did return after we left.”

“Well, they probably had some way to check on the hammer,” Bow said. “In case it would get broken.”

“Well, Ancient technology, and the Goa’uld technology they cribbed from them, lasts for a very long time,” Jack said. “Without much maintenance. Or any, in the case of the gates.”

“That might mean that this technology is different - and might require more maintenance,” Sam said. “Closer to our own, Sir.”

“Or it means the Asgard just liked to check instead of assuming everything was still working as intended,” Jack retorted with a grin.

“Then we have to assume that they are watching the gate,” Adora pointed out. “The Asgard, I mean. They have sensors in those weapons. Or devices.”

“Yep.”

“I would prefer not to test the viability of those devices,” Teal’c said. “I doubt that I would survive until the gate could be opened back to Earth, should they act like the one we encountered at the exit of the labyrinth.”

“That’s why we have the M.A.L.P., Teal’c. And SG-2.” Jack added with a grin.

Ferretti, who had just joined them as well, chuckled at that. “And, seeing as there are no guards: Are we cleared to go through the gate?” he asked.

“The sensors don’t show any dangerous radiation or contaminated air,” Sam reported.

That didn’t mean that it was safe, Adora knew. But it was probably as safe as it was going to get. “Yes. Let’s go,” she said.

“We don’t want to let the Asgard wait,” Catra added. This time, she didn’t jump over the console but followed Adora to the gate.

SG-2 moved to take point. For a moment, Adora thought about going first anyway, but… they had already had an argument today, and she didn’t want another one.

So the four men disappeared through the gate, and then it was her turn.

“Wait!” Catra said, holding her hand up. She cocked her head towards SG-1. “Are they safe over there?”

“They’re not being shot at - but they’re in that red field. It looks like the Asgard skipped the scanning,” Jack told them.

“Well, time to find out if we pass the test,” Bow said.

Adora nodded and quickly went up the ramp, stepping through the gate before Catra could catch up.

Gate travel was… disturbing. Weird. It was only a moment, but it felt longer. And weirder. Adora shook her head as she stepped out of the gate on the other side and took a deep breath. The air smelt more like Etheria than Earth. Cleaner. Fresher.

And she saw everything in a red tone since she was standing inside the field that hurt the Goa’uld. It didn’t do anything to her, though.

SG-2 had taken up positions around the gate, peering through the gap at the front. The M.A.L.P. was slowly moving through the gap.

Catra appeared behind her, scowling.

Adora acted as if she hadn’t noticed and went down the ramp. She was the best choice to take point - She-Ra was the toughest of the entire group. She could survive things that killed everyone else.

“I don’t see anyone. Last time, there was activity around the gate. And there’s the dirt road,” Ferretti looked around.

Catra sniffed the air. “I don’t smell any animals - or their shit.”

“Did something happen to the people?” Adora asked. “Did… did the Goa’uld attack, and the Asgard arrived too late to save them?”

Glimmer and Bow arrived together, Bow peering at the walls - or weapons - surrounding them and Glimmer frowning at the field.

Then Entrapta and Hordak arrived.

“Oh! Nifty!” Entrapta beamed. “I wonder if the field stays active as long as the gate is active.”

“Probably a little longer,” Hordak said. “To ensure that any Goa’uld arriving shortly before the gate closes are killed as well.”

That sounded… probable. And ruthless.

“Although I think an active scan would be a good idea anyway.” Entrapta nodded. “Just in case.”

As if the walls had heard her, a ray started scanning Ferreti - and other rays scanned everyone else.

And then a voice sounded from the walls. “Confirm your permission to visit this planet.”

Adora blinked. That was new as well, as far as she knew.

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“It looks like someone tightened down on border control. I knew we should have applied for travel visas.”

Samantha Carter didn’t react to the Colonel’s poor joke. “Thor’s Hammer was activated as soon as someone came through the gate. They scanned them afterwards - no. They must have scanned for life forms since they didn’t activate the field for the M.A.L.P. So, at least two sensor scans.” But Goa’uld would be detected just by their reaction to the effect of Thor’s Hammer.

“Permission?” she heard Adora ask through the M.A.L.P’s microphones. *“What permission?”*

“And where do we get it?” Glimmer added.

“Confirm your permission to visit this planet,” the voice repeated itself.

“Do you think this is a recording?” Daniel asked.

“It is asking a question, so they expect an answer,” the Colonel replied.

"I mean… do you think this is an automated system - or is this an actual Asgard talking to them?"

Sam adjusted the focus on the M.A.L.P.'s cameras. "Even a primitive - comparably - computer system with voice recognition and pre-recorded lines could 'talk' to visitors."

"But would the Asgard trust an automated system after we wrecked the last one?" the Colonel asked. "Or would they station troops on the planet to enforce whatever new rules they put in place?"

Before Sam could answer, Glimmer spoke up again: *"We didn't know you required permission. The people of the planet extended an invitation last time our friends visited."*

"Let's hope they didn't just mean us, specifically," the Colonel said.

Sam resisted the urge to shush him. You didn't do that to your superior.

"Well, it wasn't entirely clear, but I think the Cimmerians knew that we represented an organisation, and…"

"Shhh!" Sam hissed. Daniel wasn't her superior.

"Other visitors are free to leave the gate area. Be mindful of the laws of the planet and aware that any hostile action will be reciprocated."

"'Other visitors'? Who are you talking to?" Adora exclaimed.

"Confirm your permission to visit this planet."

Sam really wished she was on Cimmeria. Even though right now she couldn't think of anything she could do to help, she hated staying back and watching helplessly as her friends were in danger.

"Well, let's try to leave and see what happens!" Catra suggested.

"Catra, no!" Adora yelled.

But Sam saw that Catra was already moving, jumping on top of the M.A.L.P. and then through the opening in the walls surrounding the gate. She held her breath, expecting the worst - but Catra landed on all fours on the grass outside the gate area, then rose, not affected at all by anything.

"So, the bot wasn't talking to me!"

"Catra, you idiot!"

And the voice hadn't been talking to Adora since she had just charged through the gap as well, bumping the M.A.L.P. to the side, probably without noticing.

Once more, Sam was reminded that just because Adora looked and acted like a normal woman most of the time, she was a magical princess strong enough to throw tanks around. And enough power to turn spaceships into plants.

"What were you thinking?"

"Someone had to test it!"

"And that someone should've been me, not you! I'm She-Ra!"

"So? That means you get to risk your life all the time?"

"Yes!"

"You got to go through the gate first!"

"That was after SG-2 went through!"

Bow and Glimmer joined them without acrobatics or pushing expensive gear to the side. *"No magic,"* Glimmer said.

"Perhaps it is just a recording and not able to actually do anything?" Bow speculated.

SG-2 ventured out of the gate area as well. That left Entrapta and Hordak. Sam repositioned the M.A.L.P. and switched to another camera.

"Well, they have extensive sensors and… Oh! Look at those projectors, Hordak!"

"I see. But why would they hide the weapons behind worked stone? An attempt at camouflage?"

"Or they just like the style?"

"Entrapta! Can you tell if it's just a recording?"

"Give me a moment, Adora! No, I can't tell. The system is in contact with someone or something else, but I haven't cracked the encryption yet."

"Is she trying to hack the Asgard?" the Colonel asked. He sounded both impressed and aghast, Sam noted.

Before she could formulate a reply, Entrapta stepped through the gap without any trouble. But when Hordak tried to follow her, a barrier field appeared, and the voice spoke up again.

"Direct contact with the population of the planet requires permission by the Supreme Commander. Please confirm your permission or contact the closest fleet outpost."

Sam blinked. Did that mean…?

"The Asgard are the Horde?" Daniel blurted out.

"For crying out loud!"

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The Asgard Part 1

Gate Area, Cimmeria, September 26th, 1998

"The Asgard are the Horde?"

Catra shook her head at Daniel's outburst. "Can't be. Horde Prime wouldn't have protected the planet." She knew that monster.

"He would have destroyed it. Or 'reformed' it so they worshipped him." Glimmer, too, knew Horde Prime.

"I have never heard of any such policy as well - or of the Goa'uld," Hordak said.

"But the Asgard are singling you out. And they assume that you know how to contact their Supreme Commander." Entrapta frowned. "Why do they think that?"

"I don't know!" Hordak said. "I would assume that this is a splinter group of clones who chose their own path after Horde Prime's death, but the timeline does not work at all. At the time this planet was protected, Horde Prime was fighting the First Ones."

Well, he had fought them for a long time, Catra knew.

"But you're clones of Horde Prime. What if he was an Asgard who left his people to found the Horde? The depiction in the labyrinth could've been a ruse."

Sam had a good point. Horde Prime had to have come from somewhere - someone. He couldn't have just… appeared.

"We might be talking to Horde Prime's people," Adora stated the obvious. "And they're not evil!"

"We don't know that," Glimmer disagreed. "We don't know why they protected this planet."

“Well, they don’t seem too bad compared to the Goa’uld. Or your Horde,” Ferretti said.

Hordak turned to face the… well, the wall. “How can I contact the Supreme Commander? I lost my standard communication equipment.”

“The Supreme Commander has been contacted. Please wait.”

“Well, that’s one way to make contact,” Catra said. “Let’s hope Horde Prime was an outlier.”

“And let’s hope they won’t take too long to answer,” Glimmer said.

“At least the DHD is here,” Ferretti said. “We can dial back.”

But it was outside the walled section, Catra noticed. Hordak would be trapped if he were alone here.

“Yes, but our goal is to make peaceful contact with the Asgard,” Bow said. “If we leave, that’s a failure.”

Catra was tempted to tell Ferretti to head back while they stayed. “We can wait a few hours, easily. Although we might get bored.”

“We could analyse the Asgard technology!” Entrapta suggested.

“Only if you can do it without dismantling it,” Bow told her. “We don’t want to make a bad impression.”

Catra nodded in agreement. Especially if the Asgard were even a little like Hordak - or Horde Prime. “If Horde Prime has a connection to the Asgard, the technology should be familiar,” she said.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “Although the communication protocols are different compared to those Horde Prime used.”

Well, she would know. “On the other hand, they might use the same transporter Horde Prime had on his flagship,” Catra pointed out.

“Yes. Though the aesthetics are completely different as well,” Glimmer said.

And that was a good thing. Catra didn’t like Horde Prime’s style. The Asgard’s style was more like the one Alliance used on Etheria. Well, not really, but it wasn’t as polished and cold as Horde Prime’s.

Entrapta stepped back inside the gate area and fiddled with her device. “Ah. There’s some familiarity. The scanners use similar principles in how they are built and controlled. The weapons, though… I’ve never seen Horde technology use such a field.”

“I’ve never heard of anything like that, either. If Horde Prime had access to weapons that targetted specific species, I would assume they would have been used,” Hordak said.

“Unless he wanted to avoid giving his enemies ideas. If the First Ones had developed a weapon that targeted Horde Prime and all his clones…” Bow grimaced.

Catra scoffed. “I doubt that he would have been concerned about that. He was too arrogant to assume anyone could get one up on him.” And that had been part of the reason he had lost in the end.

“Yes. Still…” Glimmer was interrupted by the voice speaking up again.

“This is Thor, Supreme Commander of the Asgard Fleet. Who are you?”

Right to the top. Catra grinned despite herself.

“I am Hordak.”

“And I am Entrapta! Hi!” Entrapta waved.

"You are not one of the Asgard. Neither of you. And yet, you share our DNA."

"Ah." Hordak paused for a moment. "I am a clone of Horde Prime."

"Horde Prime?"

So the Asgard didn't know him. Or didn't want them to know they knew him.

"Our… progenitor. Creator. He cloned himself to create an army of conquest. He was defeated some time ago," Hordak replied.

"He cloned himself, you said. Was he known under another name?"

"We called him brother. Sometimes." Hordak sounded tense. Entrapta's hair patted his shoulder, Catra noticed. "We do not know where he came from - or what his species was," Hordak went on.

"Well, we have his DNA, if you're interested. But it's pretty close to Hordak's, so you probably already have it," Entrapta added.

"What brings you to Cimmeria?"

"He's with us!" Adora said, stepping into the area as well. "We're here with a team from Earth - we're friends with the people who had to dismantle your defence system to save their friend, and we came here to check if the planet needed any help - and to see if we could contact you. We're from Etheria."

"You're of Ancient descent."

"Yes." Adora looked grim.

Catra suppressed a sigh. Her lover needed to accept that her heritage didn't mean anything.

“Are you a bot? And can we meet you?” Entrapta asked. “We could share technology! Yours seems fascinating!”

Adora coughed. “We would like to meet you and apologise for destroying your defence system. And we would like to talk to you about the Goa’uld threat. We’re fighting them. Well, we will be fighting them soon.”

After a moment, the voice - Thor - replied: *“I see. Yes, I think we should meet.”*

“Great!” Adora beamed at the wall.

Catra refrained from commenting about it - they didn’t know if the Asgard had a camera pointed at them. Although if they had a DNA scanner, they should have a camera as well.

“We can close the connection to our gate so you can use it to travel,” Ferretti said.

“This will not be necessary,” Thor replied. *“I will arrive with my ship.”*

Ah. That meant the Asgard’s ship - probably more than one if they were ready to face the Goa’uld - had to be close. Relatively close.

“How long will that take?” Glimmer asked.

After a bit of back and forth, they had a time - about two hours, And wasn’t it interesting that the Asgard used Horde standard time units? Catra grinned without humour. There had to be close ties between Horde Prime and the Asgard.

“So… before you enter hyperspace…” Adora smiled in that embarrassed way of hers when she was about to confess to a blunder. “Our friends had to disable your defence system to save their friend - and our friend - Teal’c, who is a Jaffa who is opposing the Goa’uld. When they visited this planet, he was trapped in the labyrinth, and they had to destroy it to free him.”

"I am aware of the circumstances of the destruction of our first defence system."

Which didn't mean he approved of what SG-1 had done. Catra snorted.

"Good. So, can they visit as well?" Adora was still smiling. "They're sorry about the whole thing, but they had no choice. They didn't know if they could contact you - or how."

"So they destroyed our system."

The tone didn't sound like Thor approved at all. Of course, that could be different for aliens. Then again, if they were so closely related to Hordak and the other clones, they couldn't be too different.

"Yes, but they're sorry. And we're all fighting the Goa'uld, and the planet's safe, so… no harm done?" Adora's smile was obviously forced now.

"I will not judge them for one single action done out of ignorance."

"But you'll judge them later?" Catra asked before she could control herself.

"I can probably repair your system," Entrapta offered. "Or replace it with a similar one of equal value. Although you already upgraded the system here."

"The Tau'ri can visit, but your Jaffa friend should stay away."

That was a partial success - unless Thor just wanted everyone who offended them in one easy-to-bomb spot. If he arrived with a fleet, and they were all stuck on the planet…

"Thank you!" Adora said.

Well, it was better than nothing. Still, Catra would prefer if they had a flotilla with them. With Priest's bunch, they probably didn't have to worry about the clones changing allegiance when faced with some 'relatives'. But the ships would never make it here in time.

"Entering Hyperspace. Thor out."

Or so he claimed. He might be listening in still - and Catra was sure that the Asgard were still recording everything in the area. That's what she would be doing in their place.

"So… we made peaceful first contact," Bow said.

"Let's hope it stays that way." Glimmer snorted. "If a fight breaks out, we're kind of outgunned."

And, not that Catra would mention that where a potential enemy could record them, without the planet's magic restored, they were even more at a disadvantage.

It would only be five minutes to restore magic, but Catra knew her friends wouldn't do that without asking the local people first. And from what she remembered of Daniel's briefing, they might be afraid of magic like Earth's nutcases.

Adora turned to the M.A.L.P. "Jack? Did you get that?"

"Yes."

"Are you coming over?"

"That's currently being debated. In committee."

Great. Catra sighed.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 26th, 1998

“Sir, we should head through the gate,” Jack O’Neill said, staring at the observation window above them. “You heard the Asgard - we can enter.” He turned to smile apologetically at Teal’c. “Except for you. Sorry, Teal’c. They don’t know you like we do.”

“The Asgard’s hesitation to trust me is perfectly understandable.”

Of course he’d say that.

“This could be a trap, Colonel O’Neill,” Sidorov said.

“If we think it’s a trap, we should evacuate the Etherians. That’s their entire leadership out there,” Jack retorted. Not that he thought that they would let themselves be evacuated.

“They are aware of that,” General Hammond said.

At least Catra would be, in Jack’s opinion. “So, can we go through the gate?” He almost added ‘pretty please’, but the foreign generals wouldn’t appreciate it. And the Russian would take any excuse to sideline SG-1.

“We should not, how do you say, put all the eggs in one basket?” General Li said.

“Well, not showing up after we got permission could be seen as an affront,” Jack said. He suppressed the urge to rub his neck - staring up at the observation window was annoying - and glanced at Daniel.

Fortunately, Daniel was on the ball. “Ah, yes, If the Asgard have Norse values, they might see this as refusing their hospitality. Something that could be taken as an insult,” he said in his usual earnest manner.

Jack smiled. “And we don’t want to insult the alien race with spaceships and anti-Goa’uld devices and ties to a galactic conqueror.”

Sidorov, standing at the window, didn't bother hiding his scowl. But the other generals looked more reasonable. Not happy, of course.

But Jack was sure SG-1 would go through the gate - if only because they wanted someone present who was able to stand up to the Etherians - at least when it came to making decisions - when the Asgard arrived. SG-2 was a great team, but he didn't see Ferretti keeping up with the Etherians.

And Jack was right. It still took the generals five minutes to sort things out - an eternity if this had been an emergency - and Sidorov was glaring at everyone afterwards, but SG-1 got the go-ahead. Except for Teal'c, but that couldn't be helped.

"Alright! Carter, Daniel - grab your stuff and get to the gate." Jack nodded at them, then turned to Teal'c.

"Good luck, O'Neill," his friend said before Jack could say anything.

"Ah, thanks." Jack nodded at him, then turned to grab his backpack and join the others at the gate.

It was still active, so there was no need to wait. "You know the drill. No shooting the locals, no getting married by mistake even if it's to a Viking god."

"Norse god, actually. Vikings were…" Daniel started to correct him.

Jack grinned and stepped through the Stargate before his friend could finish.

Then he saw red - literally. That anti-Goa'uld field was active. As expected. He pushed the memory of the labyrinth away and faced the others. "Hey!"

"Hi! You made it!" Entrapta beamed - not at him but at Carter, who had followed him. Well, he had expected that as well. Hordak looked grumpy as ever, and Jack had to refrain from speculating

loudly what the Asgard might think about former warlords. They were being recorded, after all.

“Sir!” Ferretti nodded at him while Entrapta started talking technology with Carter - or science- and dragging Bow into it as well.

“Major.” Jack returned the nod. “Anything to report?” It was a pointless question - they had followed the mission through the M.A.L.P. - but forms had to be observed.

“No, Sir.”

“You’re early,” Catra commented as Jack stepped out of the red field. She was sitting on a tree stump nearby.

“Couldn’t wait.” Jack shrugged. “You know how it is.” She wasn’t exactly the most patient person he knew.

She laughed in return. “Well, now you can wait here with us.”

“It’s good to have you here,” Adora said with a glance at Catra.

The catwoman grinned in return and stretched, then shifted around on the tree stump as if she was sunbathing on a lounge chair.

“Catra!” Glimmer hissed.

“What? I’m not going to pretend to be busy when we’re just waiting for the Asgard to arrive.”

Well, Jack couldn’t say that he disagreed with that. But with the brass watching, he couldn’t join her or start a campfire. Although… “Daniel! You mentioned hospitality. Should we prepare a camp or something to welcome the Asgard?”

“Uh…” His friend bit his lower lip. “That’s a good question. It depends, I think, on their views of the planet. If they consider it

theirs, claiming part of it as hosts for them would be… tacky, I guess."

Or it could be seen as an invasion. Technically. Grabbing land and all.

"On the other hand," Daniel went on, "if the Asgard see this planet as belonging to the Cimmerians, they might not take offence. Or they might take offence on behalf of the Cimmerians."

"So, we better not try to invite them to roast marshmallows at our fire, got it," Jack said.

"Well, they could also be offended if we don't offer them hospitality." Daniel smiled. "It's hard to say with an alien culture. Although in Norse culture, it was generally dependent on who called a location home, so to speak."

In other words, they wouldn't know until the Asgard arrived. Like usual.

"I doubt they'll get angry," Glimmer said. "They should be used to meeting alien cultures and be aware that not everyone follows their customs."

Jack hoped she was correct. There was still the little matter of SG-1 breaking the Asgard defence system. Although, as one of its victims, Jack was ready to argue that it had been broken already - he shouldn't have been transported into the labyrinth since he didn't have a Goa'uld inside him. At best, the system's aim had been broken.

"Well," he said. "Then let's wait and hope Carter, Entrapta and Bow don't go overboard with the study of alien technology and accidentally dismantle the new defence system."

"Bow wouldn't," Glimmer retorted.

"But Entrapta and the others can get pretty enthusiastic," Adora pointed out.

"And Hordak seems a bit off his game," Catra added. "He might be too distracted to intervene."

Jack had been joking, but the Etherians seemed to take it seriously. Ah well - he trusted Carter not to go overboard. And to ride herd on the rest. She was a great officer; if she weren't an even greater scientist, she'd have her own team already.

He put his backpack down on the grass and sat on it. "So… any idea how to pass the time until Thor arrives in his shiny spaceship? If it's even shiny." Jack eyed the defence system. "It could be rather dull, of course, if this is his style."

"A spaceship made to look like it was built from stone?" Adora blinked.

"It might be using classic Norse aesthetics, such as runic decorations, maybe even some style elements from longships." Daniel got into it as well. "No sail, I would assume, though."

As they started to make silly suggestions, Jack relaxed a little. They were still meeting an alien who could hold a grudge and had a spaceship available where they were limited to small arms, but he and his team were back in the field. Where they belonged.

Things were looking up.

*****

Gate Area, Cimmeria, September 26th, 1998

"It's been two hours. I'm getting bored."

Sitting in the grass, Adora tried to ignore Catra's complaining. Yes, it had been two hours - and three minutes - since Thor had given his estimate, but he had said 'about two hours', not 'precisely two hours'.

She felt her lover shift in her lap and crane her neck so she could look at Adora's face. "Aren't you bored?"

Adora caught Catra's tail before it could flick against her nose. "No." Between listening for trouble from Entrapta, Sam and Bow and keeping Catra from starting trouble, she was quite busy.

"How? We haven't even made out to pass the time!"

"And we're all grateful for your restraint," Jack cut in.

"See? Someone appreciates my sacrifice."

Adora rolled her eyes. As if she was going to make out in front of Asgard sensors! Or her friends. Well, not beyond some kissing. "Thor's going to be here soon." He better be.

"He's probably analysing the recordings from the defence system to prepare for the meeting," Jack said. He was still sitting on his backpack, but as much as he tried to act relaxed and carefree, he never put down his rifle, Adora noticed.

"Of course he is," Glimmer said, looking directly at the closest wall.

"Entrapta should have built something to spoof the sensors," Catra said.

"That could have been considered a hostile act," Daniel cut in, looking up from his book on Norse culture. "We would effectively render the defence system partially ineffective."

"Spying on people is also a hostile act."

"It's not spying when we know there are cameras and sensors," Adora pointed out. "And we do. We could've headed back and waited at home."

"But it's much nicer here," Jack said. "Like a vacation."

Adora suppressed a sigh. Jack was still avoiding any quips about Stargate Command. No complaining about the brass, the power bill, the underground location - he must be really concerned about

leaking information. Catra, too, was sticking to quite, well, mostly personal and unimportant stuff to complain about or tease.

That, and napping and speculating about the Asgard, of course. Which counted as planning and preparing, in Adora's opinion.

"I have arrived."

Adora jumped up, dumping Catra to the ground in the process before she realised what she had done. The Asgard had arrived!

And there they were! A large, muscular human-looking man in chainmail and a steel helmet was standing near the defence system's walls. How had he appeared without anyone noticing…?

"A holoprojection," Catra said. She must have noticed a lack of smell. Or her eyes saw a flaw or something.

In any case, it was a very advanced projection - more life-like than Light Hope had been.

"Correct. I am Thor, Supreme Commander of the Asgard Fleet." He nodded. "I am currently aboard my ship in orbit."

"I am She-Ra, Princess of Power," Adora told him. "This is Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, Colonel Jack O'Neill of Stargate Command, Catra, Daniel, Major Ferreti of Stargate command, and here come Princess Entrapta of Dryl, Bow, Captain Carter and Hordak. And Dr Willard." She didn't introduce the rest of SG-2 since Casey and Bell were still guarding the gate.

"Greetings." Thor nodded.

"Hi!" Jack waved. Adora glanced at him and suppressed a frown - that wasn't how you greeted a diplomat. She wasn't the only one to glare at him, either.

But Thor didn't seem to care. He cocked his head and nodded in return. "You were the ones who destroyed the defence system of this planet."

“Well, you locked Teal’c and me up with a dangerous man-eating monster, so we had to break your prison to save us.” Jack shrugged. “I can’t say I’m too sorry about that. Indiscriminate targeting is not very polite, you know.”

“But we are sorry that we had to destroy your defence system,” Daniel quickly added.

“I understand. The circumstances that led to that situation won’t repeat themselves. We only targetted Goa’uld.”

“Not every Goau’ld is evil,” Adora cut in.

Thor turned towards her. “That may be the case, but when dealing with them, it is better to err on the side of caution.”

Adora pressed her lips together. Killing every Goa’uld by default wasn’t exactly cautious, in her opinion. But before she could say anything, Thor went on: “But as I understand, the situation was resolved, and you are now aware that this planet represents a lethal danger to your Jaffa friend. I don’t think this needs further debate.” He turned to Hordak. “You share our genes, yet you aren’t one of us. You didn’t know us - or of us - either. And you are a clone.”

“Yes.” Hordak nodded and stared at Thor. Adora couldn’t read him well, but he looked tense. Very tense.

“A clone of who?”

Hordak raised his chin. “Horde Prime. He made us - my brothers and me - in his image.”

“I do not know this name.”

“I’m not impressed by their intelligence gathering capability,” Catra whispered. “Even the Goa’uld knew about Horde Prime,” she added a bit more loudly.

“We do not share information or anything else with the Goa’uld,” Thor told her.

“Other than being revered as gods by people,” Jack said with an innocent-looking smile. “And hiding your true appearance.”

Thor frowned at him again. “That is correct. We chose an appearance that suited the local civilisation. Our true appearance is, as you have undoubtedly deduced, different from humans or Ancients.”

Ah. Adora nodded. That made sense - they probably looked more like Hordak since they shared enough DNA to mistake him for an Asgard.

Entrapta pouted. “But why are you hiding your appearance from us? We aren’t Cimmerians, and we already know you aren’t human. I’ve been told it’s polite and respectful to show your true face.”

“And there’s no Cimmerian around,” Jack said. He made a show to look around. “Unlike last time we visited - they chanted your name when we arrived.

“The local population has been advised to avoid the gate area for the time being,” Thor told them. “While the defences should be enough to repel a Goa’uld invasion, collateral damage is still a threat.”

“That explains their absence. If your god tells you to avoid an area, you generally do it, right?” Jack asked with an innocent expression that, Adora knew from experience, was fake.

“It was deemed the best way to interact with the people without disrupting their civilisation more than absolutely necessary,” Thor said.

“Ah!” Daniel nodded. “Does that mean you used an existing pantheon as your role model, or did you create the Norse pantheon from, uh, scratch?”

Thor hesitated a moment. “We did build our appearance on the local culture, but we did not lay claim to any gods.”

That was… probably a good thing. But they were still worshipped as gods. Which was a bad thing - Adora could attest to that personally. You didn’t claim you were a god!

“So, you took the Cimmerians’ ancestors from Earth to raise them here, safe from the Goa’uld?” Jack asked in the same innocent tone as before.

“Yes.” Thor apparently took him at face value. “We wanted to allow them to develop without being manipulated by the Goa’uld - or anyone else. Which is why we did not contact them directly afterwards.”

“Except for leaving proof of your existence by planting your hammer at the Stargate.” Jack nodded.

“That was a necessity.”

“And you’ve been watching over the planet since then?” Adora asked.

“Rather distantly,” Catra added before Thor could answer.

The projection nodded. “We didn’t want to interfere. And we didn’t - until you forced our hand. We have taken steps to avoid a repeat of such a situation.”

That sounded good to Adora. She smiled at the projection.

“But I came to see you because of you,” Thor said, turning back to Hordak. “You said you do not know the origin of your creator.”

“I do not.” Hordak shook his head. “Horde Prime… never said anything about that.”

“He liked to give the impression that he was eternal,” Glimmer added. “That he was always there and would always be there.”

“Yes,” Hordak said. “I never questioned this - I never speculated who might have been his parent. Or his creator.”

He wasn’t looking at Thor as he told them that, Adora noticed.

“I see.” Thor nodded. “Regretable.”

“Of course,” Catra spoke up. “I don’t think the clones actually looked into Horde Prime’s origin.”

“Most of us wanted to forget our past, I believe,” Hordak said.

Hordak sounded like he was one of them, Adora thought.

“But it means we might be able to help shed some light on this mystery,” Catra went on. She smiled widely at Thor, showing her fangs.

Adora pressed her lips together. She knew that expression - Catra thought she had spotted an opportunity.

Thor wasn’t fooled either, judging by his frown. “And what do you expect in exchange for your help?”

“Nothing for me, personally.” Catra’s grin widened. “But since you obviously don’t like the Goa’uld and kill them on sight, maybe we should be talking about that as well, instead of just talking about Hordak’s ancestors.”

That was a good point. A great point, actually. Adora nodded. “Yes. If we’re both fighting the Goa’uld, we should coordinate our efforts.” And maybe form an alliance.

Once more, Thor hesitated a moment before answering. That didn’t seem to be a good thing.

“Are you fighting the Goa’uld as well?” Jack asked.

“We have a treaty with the System Lords - the Protected Planets Treaty,” Thor said.

"And what are the terms of the treaty?" Glimmer asked when he didn't go on.

"The System Lords are forbidden from attacking a protected planet and are obligated to keep rogue Goa'uld from attacking. In exchange, the Asgard ensure that the protected planets do not threaten the Goa'uld."

Adora blinked. That sounded…

"And did the protected planets agree to this treaty?" Glimmer asked. She turned to look at Jack. "The Cimmerians didn't tell you anything about it, did they?"

Jack shook his head. "Nope."

"Although we only talked to their local leader - the wife of the local ruler," Daniel added. "She mentioned he had gone to look for work in a city, so the rulers there might know about the treaty."

Adora frowned again. The Stargate of the planet was in a remote location. A backwater location. That said a lot about how important it was for the planet. Or how important it was supposed to be for the planet.

"The treaty is between the Asgard and the Goa'uld. The populations of the protected planets aren't sufficiently advanced to actually pose a threat to the Goa'uld."

"Are they like the Cimmerians?" Daniel asked. "Culturally, I mean. And technologically, although that is so heavily entwined with a planet's culture, it's often hard to draw a clear distinction, even if traditions tend to linger past the point where what caused them to develop was rendered obsolete by technology."

Thor tilted his head. "The protected planets have a wide range of cultures. We didn't intend to be revered by the people on this planet."

“But you were also revered on Earth - by a part of the population,” Daniel pointed out.

“Yes. That was also not intended.” Thor looked… annoyed. Or embarrassed? It was hard to tell, with the helmet covering half his face. And all being a projection, of course.

“So, you accidentally got worshipped as gods?” Jack raised his eyebrows. “Well, that could happen to anyone, I guess,” he added with a shrug.

Adora frowned at him. Yes, it could happen accidentally! Or at least unintentionally!

“The level of native technology of this planet doesn’t seem to have advanced very much since they were taken from Earth,” Sam said.

“We have not interfered with their development,” Thor said.

“Except for becoming their gods.” Jack grinned, showing his teeth.

“Yes. We strive to avoid intervening unless something or someone forces our hand.” Thor nodded.

Daniel adjusted his glasses. “But despite the treaty, you don’t like the Goa’uld. You didn’t just block them from reaching this planet - you built an elaborate system to capture any of them who arrived, where the only way to escape was for the Goa’uld to release their hosts.”

“Yes.”

Daniel nodded. “The Goa’uld must be aware of that as well. And yet, they made a treaty with you. I don’t think they would have done that if they thought they could defeat you in an all-out war. Or, at least, defeat you without fatally weakening their own Empire. The Asgard must be a credible threat to them for such a treaty to be agreed upon.”

“Our technology is superior to theirs,” Thor replied.

“Quite a specific wording,” Catra whispered. She was right, in Adora’s opinion.

Glimmer, though, was nodding. “So, if you joined forces with us, we could likely defeat them easily.” She was smiling, but it was a guarded smile, Adora noticed. Her friend didn’t expect Thor to agree with her.

“Unless the Goa’uld break the treaty, the Asgard will not declare war on them.”

“So, you won’t break your own treaty.” Jack nodded.

“Thor was supposed to be very honourable in our myths. As were most gods of the Norse pantheon. Loki was the most notable and famous - or infamous - exception,” Daniel said in a low voice.

And Adora saw Thor frown at the name.

“Or maybe you can’t afford to go to war?” Catra asked, cocking her head to the side as her ears twitched. “Is there something else keeping you from moving against the Goa’uld?”

Thor frowned at her. “How could you trust an alliance with someone who broke a treaty?”

That was a good point, Adora had to admit. She nodded in agreement.

“That depends on whether or not the treaty was made in good faith - and if it wasn’t forced on either side,” Glimmer said.

Thor inclined his head but didn’t answer the unspoken question. “We seem to be at an impasse.”

“Maybe we should discuss this face to face,” Jack said. “You know, it’s hard to trust someone when you know they’re hiding their true

appearance and pretty much everything else." His smile reminded Adora of Catra's when she thought she had the upper hand.

After a moment, Thor nodded. "Very well. If you give your word not to offer violence, we can meet in person on my ship."

"We accept your hospitality," Daniel said, nodding slowly. Then he glanced at Jack and raised his eyebrows.

"Yes." Jack nodded as well - a little exaggeratedly, in Adora's opinion. "You have our word."

"Yes!" Entrapta beamed. She was the only one, though.

Adora glanced at Catra, but her lover nodded as well without adding anything - for once. And Glimmer frowned a little but didn't say anything either.

"So, are you going to send a shuttle down, or…?" Jack was interrupted by a peculiar noise.

Adora saw Catra and Glimmer clench their teeth and jerk, but a moment later, they were standing on the bridge of a ship in space.

*****

Orbit above Cimmeria, September 26th, 1998

Matter transportation - or teleportation, Samantha Carter thought as she got her bearings after the sudden shift. She didn't see any sign of a ring transporter, and it hadn't felt like a ring transporter, either. Magic was unlikely - the planet hadn't had its magic restored - but couldn't be eliminated as a possible source since She-Ra proved that some magic worked without that.

They were on a bridge - or a command centre. Darker than she had expected, with a few screens and consoles, but she couldn't see anyone manning them, and…

"Oh, for crying out loud!"

The Colonel's exclamation had her turn around and… freeze for a moment as a figure stepped out of the shadows.

"Welcome to the Biliskner, my flagship."

Thor was a grey humanoid alien, smaller than an average human, with a proportionally big head, solid black eyes, and no visible genitals. And no clothes, either. In short, he looked like the depictions of aliens in some science fiction media - and in some tales of being kidnapped by aliens, which likely prompted the Colonel's outburst.

"Hello! Thank you for inviting us!" Adora, like the rest of the Etheirans, didn't seem to be affected. No, Sam corrected herself - Catra and Glimmer looked around like they were in hostile territory. And the Colonel muttered something about 'probing' that probably shouldn't be overheard.

"Well, it's definitely not designed or decorated in the Norse style," Daniel said.

"We do not impose our own culture on others," Thor said. He was staring at Hordak, though.

The former warlord looked around. "It's not Horde Prime's style either," he said. "But the technology…"

"It's quite similar!" Entrapta smiled widely as she pointed her recorder around. "Not identical, but here, you can easily see that it's based on the same principles and key technology."

"Yeah, the transporter felt very familiar," Glimmer muttered.

"I see." Thor nodded. "That would be another indicator that you are… descendants of the Asgard."

Daniel blinked. "Descendants? Are you sure? If the culture doesn't show any shared origin, only similar technology, couldn't it be parallel evolution?"

“Our species’ history is well-documented,” Thor replied. “If there are close similarities between our technology and the technology this ‘Horde Prime’ used, then that would indicate that he had access to our technology relatively recently.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded several times. “That would fit the differences!”

Sam was inclined to agree based on her own readings.

“But would the timeline of the Horde fit?” Daniel asked with a slight pout - he didn’t like letting go of a theory.

“As I mentioned before, Horde Prime didn’t encourage us to delve into his past. But I think it would fit - I certainly do not recall anything that would disprove the notion.” Hordak stared at Thor. “Although the differences in appearance are striking.”

“But DNA doesn’t lie,” Entrapta said. She pointed her device at Thor, and Sam winced. That was rather rude. If Thor took offence… “Oh!” Entrapta blinked. “You’re a clone as well!”

“What?” The Colonel blurted out.

“It would be more correct to say that this body is a clone. My consciousness is far older than this,” Thor said.

Now the Etherians tensed. Especially Catra, Glimmer and Hordak.

“Horde Prime could transfer his consciousness into the bodies of his clones,” Hordak said. “He was able to possess any single one of us any time he chose so.”

Oh. That would explain it. The ramifications of this… No wonder they hadn’t mentioned this before.

Thor seemed unfazed, though. “Yes. This is also an old technology of my species. Although we do not use it on other sapients - we use specifically created braindead clones. Nevertheless, it seems Horde Prime had access to a wide range of Asgard technology.”

Which would support the theory that Horde Prime had been created by an Asgard. Like the Ancient experiments on Etheria. "Does your species have a history of experimenting with new life forms?" Sam asked before she realised how rude it sounded. But it seemed everyone else was focusing on Thor.

"My species? No." Thor was… well, Sam had no experience or point of reference to judge the alien's expression, but he seemed to be frowning. "But individuals have done such research in the past."

"Undocumented and uncontrolled research, right?" Catra shook her head. "Since you somehow missed how a clone with your DNA started a conquest of the galaxy."

Thor inclined his head. "There have been experiments without permission from the High Council in the past. Some of our scientists felt 'hobbled' by our laws. It would not be out of character for some to hide their research, no matter how dangerous or short-sighted it would be."

"Yep, we know about such people as well," the Colonel said. "Short-sighted and law-breaking, I mean - we haven't actually had scientists create a new species and set them loose on the galaxy."

"Well, I know a few scientists who would likely do that - if they had the means," Daniel said.

Sam nodded in agreement. She knew a number of such people herself. And she didn't miss how Entrapta looked a little guilty.

"So, it looks like the Asgard aren't the Horde - but the Horde came from the Asgard," the Colonel summed up. "Does that mean you're like… cousins? Or are you Hordak's uncle? Great-uncle?"

Hordak frowned at the Colonel, but Thor tilted his head. "The exact legal relationship remains to be determined. So far, it's merely a theory. We cannot exclude the possibility that someone else captured an Asgard and used them for such experiments."

“Yes,” Adora said. “Some people will experiment on people like that.” She blinked. “You know what I mean:”

“We do,” Catra told her with a grin. Then she turned to Thor. “So, when will you interrogate your suspect?”

Thor looked surprised for a moment, then slowly nodded. “They are sometimes hard to get ahold of. But we will get to the bottom of this.”

Which meant that he did have a suspect in mind. Sam nodded.

“And we will help you!” Entrapta beamed again. “Right, Hordak?”

Hordak nodded very slowly. “Yes. This is important.”

“Yes, it is. For both of our species.” Thor said.

“And speaking of important things,” the Colonel broke the short silence. “How about we talk about our common enemy again? You were explaining why you couldn’t fight the snakes before you invited us to your fine ship here.”

Thor seemed to tense up again - at least Sam thought so.

That wasn’t a good sign for a possible alliance.

*****

The Asgard Part 2

Orbit above Cimmeria, September 26th, 1998

Thor was hiding something; Catra was sure. And it was related to the Goa'uld. You didn't stick to a treaty with enemies you killed on sight on your world just because your word was your bond or something. If you wanted to break a treaty, you could always find a reason or pretext. Just the fact that the Goa'uld had visited Cimmeria in the past should be enough of a pretext - if you actually wanted to fight them.

Daniel might assume that it was their honour that kept the Asgard back, but Catra doubted that. The whole setup where Goa'uold died as they set foot on the planet didn't really look honourable to her. More like something someone would do who wanted to stick to the letter of an agreement but bend its spirit as much as possible. Someone who wanted to fight them.

So, something had prevented the Asgard from fighting the Goa'uld all-out and made them make a treaty instead. She cocked her head and looked around. "That's a very nice bridge here. Looks like a nice ship overall."

"Thank you." Thor nodded at her.

"How does it stack up against a Ha'tak?" she asked.

"Our technology is superior. A Ha'Tak stands no chance against this ship - or any of our ships."

She had expected that. If they had similar technology to Horde Prime, they would be superior to the Goa'uld's technology. So… they had the quality. And the will. What did that leave?

Numbers. Which was weird since they had cloning technology. They should be able to grow an army if they needed one. Like Horde Prime had done. This was quite a mystery. Ah, screw it.

Catra grinned. “So, what’s holding you back from protecting more planets? Not enough ships?”

Thor frowned at her. At least it looked like a frown. “I assume you will understand that I’m not at liberty to discuss the Asgard military with strangers.”

“Of course we understand that!” Adora said at once with a glance at Catra. Then she smiled at Thor. “It’s just… You obviously consider the Goa’uld a threat. And I doubt that you trust them to stick to the treaty if they think they could break it without consequences.”

“Yeah,” Jack cut in, “The way you set up a roach motel and now a bug zapper for the Goa’uld kinda gives that away.”

Catra frowned - a roach motel?

“It’s a slang term for a vermin trap on Earth,” Daniel explained.

Ah. She nodded - and noticed that Thor was still tense. Kind of. Definitely hiding something.

“So, you know they aren’t trustworthy.” Glimmer nodded.

“We do. But we aren’t like them,” Thor retorted.

“Did they trap you in the treaty?” Daniel asked. “Did they exploit your honour?” Thor turned towards him, and Daniel smiled a bit embarrassedly. “I’m sorry. I didn’t want to pry - my curiosity got the better of me.”

Thor nodded again, and Catra told herself that she should take notes. Daniel really knew how to get away with stuff.

“As I said, we will not break the treaty.” Thor looked at Hordak. “And should the Goa’uld accuse us of doing so because they mistook you for an Asgard, we will tell them so.”

“We wouldn’t try to trick the Goa’uld like that!” Entrapta protested.

“Yes. That would be low,” Adora agreed.

Catra eyed Jack. He was looking composed, but she was sure that he disagreed with Adora and Entrapta.

Hell, Catra would disagree with them - if she thought that the Asgard were only held back by their honour. As it was, it would be a bad idea to trick them into joining the war. Not least because they might enter on the side of Goa’uld if they suspected treachery.

They needed to know more about the Asgard. With their ties to the Horde, their technology, their relation to the Goa’uld… they were just too important for the war.

“Alright. But we’ll still work on finding out what your relation to the Horde is, right?” Bow said.

“Yes. We need to know what happened - and if any of our laws were broken. And by whom.”

“And you’ll share your information, right?” Entrapta beamed at him. “Sharing knowledge is essential for science! And for trust-building.” She nodded emphatically.

“And you’re kind of family already,” Catra added.

Both Hordak and Thor twitched.

She didn’t care. If the Asgard were responsible for Horde Prime, then this was nothing. Hell, if they were responsible, Catra would probably be for tricking them into the war against the Goa’uld.

But they needed to know more about them first.

Thor once more slowly nodded. “Yes, we will be sharing what we find out.”

Catra suppressed a snort. Sure they would - once they had removed anything sensitive.

But most of her friends were smiling. Especially Daniel.

She sighed.

*****

Jack O'Neill smiled politely at the grey alien. 'We will not break the treaty' my ass, he thought. The guy was hiding something - you didn't build elaborate death traps for your enemies if you wanted to honour your treaty with them. That was what you did if you wanted to go as far as you could without breaking the treaty because you needed it.

"So… you won't join in the fight against the Goa'uld. But what if the people under your protection want to fight them? How many planets are under your protection, anyway?" He raised his hands. "Just so we won't have to dismantle another of your defence systems."

"We currently protect twenty-seven planets," Thor replied after a moment. "I will send you the gate addresses."

Jack didn't miss that Thor hadn't answered his first question.

Daniel hadn't missed that either. "And what if the Cimmerians want to open diplomatic relations? With Earth or the Etherians?"

"We would want assurances that they aren't exploited," Thor replied. "We are aware of your planet's history - and your species's past," he added with a nod towards Adora.

Oh shit. Of course they would know that Jack, too, had some alien genes. And draw the wrong conclusions. "I wasn't aware of my 'ancestry' until a few months ago," Jack said.

"I didn't know I was one of the First Ones for most of my life." Adora nodded with a grim expression as Catra held her hand, Jack

noted. “Neither of us was raised as an Ancient.”

“Your biology doesn’t decide your life,” Daniel added.

“Well, except for when it does - like if you have a genetic predisposition to specific illnesses or something. Or your brain chemistry is affected,” Entrapta said. “And there are some instincts and urges tied to certain genes, I believe.” Jack frowned at her, and she blinked. “But that’s probably not what you meant, right?” she asked with a smile, looking at everyone in the room.

“Yes, We’re just saying that Adora and Jack aren’t going to act like Ancients just because they are descendants of them,” Bow said.

“And they’ve never met them.” Entrapta nodded again. “Unless Light Hope and Alpha count, although they aren’t First Ones, they were raised by First Ones. That’s actually like the opposite of you two - they don’t have the genetic legacy but they have knowledge about their culture. Some knowledge, at least.”

“Who are those people?” Thor asked. “We have lost contact with the Ancients long ago. If they are still present in the galaxy, we would like to talk to them again.”

So, they had had contact with the Ancients. And they used cloned bodies to transfer their minds into. How old were those aliens? Jack wondered.

“They’re bots. Artificial intelligences,” Entrapta replied. “Or were, in Light Hope’s case,” she added with a frown. “She didn’t survive the fight against Horde Prime.”

“Ah.” Thor looked disappointed - if Jack read his expression correctly. Did they need to contact the Ancients, or was it just sentimentality? He wished he knew the Asgard as well as he knew Teal’c so he could read them.

“So, you’re protecting planets while we fight the Goa’uld,” Glimmer said. “That will be helpful since that means we have to protect fewer planets.”

Oh, that was a nice dig! Jack's smile grew more honest - everyone here knew that the Goa'uld oppressed a lot more than a few dozen planets.

"Yes," Thor replied.

"Could you provide humanitarian aid to liberated planets?" Jack asked, trying to sound earnest. "Food, for example?"

This time, Thor frowned. "That would likely be seen as breaking the treaty."

"And would you let Cimmerians come to us to fight the Goa'uld?" Jack tilted his head.

Thor mirrored his gesture. "We aren't their gods or rulers. We just keep them safe from the Goa'uld."

"But you also keep the Goa'uld safe from them. That was a clause in the treaty you mentioned." Daniel narrowed his eyes. "So, wouldn't that be breaking the treaty as well?"

"Depending on the scale of the involvement, Cimmerians who take part in the war would be considered rogue elements," Thor told him.

"And what if we shared our technology with them?" Catra asked. "I'm not saying we would do it - we have quite strict conditions for such technology transfers - but what if we did and they would accept?"

"Even if you shared all your technology today, they would take years to learn enough to maintain, much less recreate your technology without your help," Thor told her.

Catra grinned. So did Jack. "So, you'd blame us, I take it, if the Goa'uld complained, and claimed that it's us, not the Cimmerians, who are a threat."

Thor nodded, and Jack thought he saw the alien's mouth twist in a brief smile. Well, as Supreme Commander of the Asgard Fleet, the alien would know how to play these games.

So, he might not be a bad guy after all. But he was still hiding something. Something important.

Jack was sure of that.

*****

This was going better than Adora had feared, but not as well as she had hoped. The Asgard were friendly but didn't want to join the war against the Goa'uld. Even though they didn't like the Goa'uld and had superior technology - on par or better with the Horde's technology. Well, they would have their reasons, even if Adora didn't know them. That treaty, on the other hand, sounded a little… it sounded like a temporary solution that no one was actually happy with and everyone knew wouldn't last forever.

And you were supposed to plan ahead if you knew something wouldn't last. So… "What will you do once the Goa'uld break the treaty?"

Thor tilted his head as he turned to look at her. "That depends on the exact circumstances, but we have a commitment to defend the protected planets."

"Mourir pour Danzig?" Jack muttered.

Adora frowned - she didn't understand the reference. But she knew evasive answers when she heard them.

"I assume that you have plans for that case," Glimmer commented. "You know the Goa'uld aren't trustworthy."

"We know that they wouldn't dare to break the treaty," Thor retorted.

"At least not openly," Catra cut in.

“And they are divided - they cannot trust each other, which means they cannot unite to wage war. Not unless circumstances force them to unite,” Thor went on, looking at Glimmer.

“Circumstances like an enemy starting to dismantle their empire and free their slaves?” Glimmer met Thor’s eyes.

“It is a possibility. Your technology is obviously similar to ours and, therefore, superior to the Goa’uld technology. If you also have the numbers to pose a credible threat, that could unite the Goa’uld,” Thor said.

Adora pressed her lips together. They were aware of that - they would do their best to avoid that.

“Allies with the same technology and goals could counter even a united Goa’uld Empire,” Glimmer pointed out.

“In a war that will lay waste to a significant part of the galaxy,” Thor retorted. “And while we have solid estimates of the strength of the Goa’uld, we don’t have any of your strength.”

Well, of course the Asgard didn’t know about their forces - they hadn’t even known about Etheria until today!

“The Goa’uld knew Horde Prime yet avoided conflict with him,” Glimmer pointed out. “I doubt they would have done so if they thought they could defeat him.”

“And they must have known that he would not stop with our sector but continue his campaign to conquer the galaxy,” Catra added. “Yet they didn’t unite.” Her ears turned forward as she grinned. “They probably hoped the First Ones and Horde Prime would kill each other - or at least weaken each other so much, the Goa’uld could finish off the victor. But that didn’t happen.”

“And then you defeated him. But how much did it cost you?” Thor asked.

Catra frowned - her ears were laid back again, Adora noticed. Did she see the question as a threat? Was it a threat?

Adora couldn't tell. Technically, if you ignored all the devastation suffered over two decades of war, Etheria had gained a lot from the war - the support of Second and Third and the remnants of First Fleet. But without the unknown rest of Horde Prime's forces, cut off by his death, they were still facing an enemy with a significant numerical superiority.

"It cost us enough so we know we can't let the Goa'uld keep oppressing and enslaving people," Glimmer said. "We've seen the destruction Horde Prime wrought on other people." She shook her head. "We can't let them keep doing this to others."

Thor didn't react for a moment. "We won't break our treaty."

"Well, I'm sure you have a good reason for that. But you better be ready for the day the Goa'uld think they can break the treaty and get away with it," Jack said.

"That day may come, but not soon," Thor said.

"Well, the Goa'uld might have held back in the hope that you'd fight Horde Prime," Catra said. "Who knows what they'll do now?"

"If they saw Horde Prime as such a threat as you claim, then they will want to find out who defeated him," Thor retorted.

He had a point. The Goa'uld wouldn't start a war with the Asgard now. Certainly not after the Alliance had begun their attacks. Adora pressed her lips together. The Alliance would be protecting the Asgard as well, in a way. Usually, she didn't mind protecting people, but this was a little different.

Why couldn't they just do the right thing and join them?

"So… seems we have reached an understanding," Jack said, smiling in a way that reminded Adora of Catra trying to pull something over her. "But since we're sharing information and all…

Are there any other dangers like the Goa'uld that we should be aware of when we start exploring the galaxy?"

Thor froze for a moment, then cocked his head sideways, staring at Jack. "We aren't aware of any danger for an advanced species that aren't contained already. Although our knowledge of what the Ancients left behind is limited. The Stargates are the most famous of their achievements, but also the safest."

Adora blinked. That sounded ominous.

"Really?" Entrapta sounded intrigued.

Adora swallowed a curse.

Catra, standing at her side, didn't.

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"We need to find them, then," Entrapta went on. "If they were left in a state like the Heart of Etheria, they could go out of control as well."

Samantha Carter nodded in agreement. "Given the scope of the Ancients' technology, I believe ensuring that there are no lingering dangers is necessary," she said.

"And analysing their technology will allow us not only to handle such dangers but also to greatly advance our own technology!" Entrapta beamed. "They were so far advanced compared to us!"

Sam agreed with that as well.

"Well, I'm not too comfortable with poking the possible world-destroying device," the Colonel said with a grimace.

"Oh, do not misunderstand, Colonel O'Neill. The danger that relics of the Ancients represent goes far beyond destroying a world," Thor said.

“Ah. How silly of me to worry about a mere world-destroying threat.” The Colonel chuckled once.

“Well, if you’re on the planet, it’s still a great danger,” Entrapta said. “And for everyone else in the world, of course.”

That made the Colonel blink at her. Fortunately, he just nodded instead of commenting in his sarcastic way. Entrapta meant well, after all.

“Although the lack of magic in many worlds might have affected any technology left by the Ancients,” Entrapta went on, wrinkling her nose. “They were using magic, after all, so their technology would also be using it.”

“Not all of their technology used magic,” Thor pointed out. “The Stargates do not rely on it.”

Sam nodded. So, Thor was aware of magic. Well, if he was as old as he had hinted at, he would have experienced magic before it was siphoned off.

“Oh!” Adora looked embarrassed as she smiled at him. “Speaking of magic… do you wish to have it returned to your world? If you lost it, I mean. I can do it - we figured out how the First Ones took the magic from the other planets through the Stargates.”

Once more, Thor tilted his head in that not quite alien way that might indicate surprise unless Sam was misinterpreting his reaction. “You can restore magic to a world?”

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. “And it won’t take long either.”

“Interesting. Thank you for the offer, but the Asgard do not use magic. We don’t have the talent for it, so its lack does not affect us.”

“Really?” Entrapta looked surprised. “None of you can use magic? What about magitech devices?”

“We prefer to rely on our own technology.”

A non-answer, like others, Sam noted. And, in her private opinion, at least, a rather short-sighted policy. One should never dismiss new knowledge or technology out of hand. On the other hand, that was the business of the Asgard, not hers.

“If you’re sure…” Adora pouted a little.

“Not everyone wants magic forced into their lives,” the Colonel said - a little too smugly, Sam found. The Etherians meant well, after all.

“And does everyone on your worlds share that view?” Glimmer asked.

“Yes.” Thor nodded. “We’re an old species. We didn’t miss magic when it was gone.”

“But the potential magic offers! It’s a whole field of technology you’re missing out on!” Entrapta protested.

“We prefer to work with technology that we not only fully understand but also fully control.”

“But…” Entrapta started to retort when Hordak put his hand on her shoulder.

“I understand the feeling,” he said. “Horde Prime had the same policy.” After a moment, he added: “Although he destroyed what he couldn’t control.”

“We are not like him,” Thor replied in a tense tone.

“And we’re all glad for that,” the Colonel said. “So, you don’t have a list of worlds to avoid unless we want to risk unleashing an ancient but not quite galaxy.-destroying evil, do you?”

“No.”

Sam tried not to feel disappointed. Wanting to analyse and explore such dangerous worlds was reckless and should be discouraged. Even though she couldn't help wanting to anyway.

"Aw." Entrapta didn't bother to hide her disappointment. "So, what about exchanging technology? We've got similar technology, after all, so I am sure there would be quite the synergies." She beamed at Thor.

"That would require a decision of the High Council of the Asgard," Thor told her. Sam noticed Daniel perking up. "However, we generally do not share our technology unless it is with species which have proven themselves to be mature enough to use it."

"Now, that sounds familiar!"

And the Colonel sounded a bit too smug again.

Adora frowned at him in return. "It's a sensible policy," she said.

"But we already have comparable technology," Entrapta pointed out. "It's not as if you'd uplift us."

Well, the Etherians had comparable technology. Earth still lacked it. Sam pressed her lips together; she would have loved to get access to their technology. On the other hand, it didn't look like the Asgard would be a way to circumvent the Etherians' conditions for sharing technology. And that wasn't a bad thing with the Stargate Command now under United Nations control; Sam wasn't quite as opinionated about it as the Colonel was, but she didn't think China and Russia could be trusted with such technology either.

Though she really hoped that the United States would finally manage to pass the necessary laws to negotiate an Alliance with the Etherians.

"As I said, that is up to the High Council to decide," Thor said.

"Aw."

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"...and here's how to contact us once your High Council has made a decision. You can use this after dialling Earth's Stargate."

Catra smirked as Bow handed a communicator over to Thor. "Just don't try to go through the gate - you'll get flattened."

"I see." Thor looked at her and nodded. He didn't ask if they had a Stargate of their own - he probably assumed that the Alliance with Earth covered the whole planet and was much older than it was - and more stable - and so they would only give out Earth's gate address.

"And how can we contact you?" Glimmer asked.

"Visit Cimmeria and address the defence system."

Thor wasn't smiling, but Catra would bet that he was amused. He just had a smug attitude there.

"Then we've settled everything that could be settled now," she said. "Unless you'd like to give us a tour of your ship, we probably should head home."

"Yes." Adora nodded.

Entrapta smiled at Thor, obviously hoping for a tour. But, instead, the damn transporter that was so similar to Horde Prime's went off again. Catra tensed - he wasn't Horde Prime. The Asgard weren't the Horde - and then they were standing near the Stargate on Cimmeria, and she heard Ferretti call in his radio that they were back.

"Alright!" O'Neill clapped his hands. "Doesn't look like any of the natives are around, so let's head back!"

"Jack! We still haven't contacted Kendra!" Daniel complained. "In fact, we haven't talked to any Cimmerian, and we don't know what they think about this!"

“We can return after we briefed the brass,” O’Neill retorted, glancing at the walls housing the defence system.

“But this is an opportunity to compare their views to the claims made by the Asgard,” Daniel protested.

“And we can do that once we have had our debriefing about our meeting with the Norse god. Major - clear us to return!”

“Yes, Sir!” Ferretti used his radio again, sending a code. “Clear, Sir!”

If he was mistaken, this would be a very quick way to die, Catra knew. If anyone wanted to sabotage the Alliance, this would be the way.

But she had to trust that Stargate Command wouldn’t let that happen. The British and the French had an alliance with them, and the United States wanted an alliance. Still, all it would take was one person at the controls, closing the iris at the right moment…

But they arrived safely at Stargate Command.

Still no sign of hidden defence installation like gunports. But the guards were alert. And the doors out of the gate room were closed, she noted - sealed if she interpreted the lights above it correctly. And there was Frasier coming towards them, wearing a mask and carrying several vials.

“Oh, no… we’ve been on Cimmeria before, Doc!” O’Neill complained.

“That was before you met an alien species and visited their ship. We’ll need to give you a full check,” the doctor replied.

“I’ve already scanned for biological agents,” Entrapta said. “I didn’t find anything but the normal stuff, you know.”

“Normal stuff?” Daniel asked.

“Microbes and such native to the planet. If they didn’t hurt you on your last visit, they shouldn’t hurt you.”

“We’ll still check ourselves,” Dr Frasier said. “Your arm, please, Colonel.”

O’Neill grumbled but held out his arm to the doctor.

“But it’s really not necessary,” Entrapta insisted. “My scanner didn’t show any dangerous agents.”

“The dear doctor sticks to procedure,” O’Neill said while the woman switched to Daniel.

“No one ever died because of one examination too many, Colonel.”

“Are you sure? I feel as if I gave a gallon of blood already.”

“Then you wouldn’t be able to talk back, Sir. You’d be unconscious or dead.”

Catra snickered at the exchange, which made Adora hiss at “Catra!” at her.

Frasier went on to get blood from Sam, then switched to SG-2. None of them complained. Once she was finished, she looked at Adora and hesitated.

“We trust our own specialists,” Glimmer told her.

Catra nodded. She didn’t want the humans to have her blood. Who knew what they would do with it?

“Yes! We’re safe!” Entrapta said.

“And I can heal anyone, anyway,” Adora said, raising her sword.

A moment later, light filled the room, followed by surprised gasps - Catra felt the hairs of her fur stand up for a moment as magic touched her. “Show-off,” she whispered.

Adora pouted at her. "I just wanted to reassure our allies."

"Well, they don't look very reassured," Catra told her as she nodded at Frasier, who was eyeing her samples as if she expected the blood to turn into a monster and attack her.

"Oh… I didn't think of that."

Catra shrugged. "They'll get over it." She had no doubt that the blood samples would now be examined for any traces of magic - though she had no idea if the humans knew how to do that.

It didn't matter anyway - it was time to get debriefed by the council of generals. Catra just hoped they wouldn't be too annoying; she wanted to get back to the ship and relax now, after meeting what probably was Hordak's grand-uncle or something.

She snorted at the thought. She'd have to remember that for their next meeting.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 26th, 1998

"...and then we were transported down to the planet again - abruptly - and proceeded to return to base," Jack O'Neill finished his oral report. Which he would have to deliver in writing as well because even with the change in management, getting a clerk to type out a transcript was still impossible because all of it was classified, and no clerk with the necessary security clearance was on the roster.

"Thank you, Colonel." Hammond nodded.

"A peaceful contact with an advanced species - as advanced as the Etherians," General Li commented.

Or more advanced - Jack hadn't seen them use such a transporter before.

“Yes,” Entrapta said. “They have technology similar to the Horde, although with some differences; likely the result of different design and research choices since they split off.”

“So, you think the Asgard are the creators of the Horde?” General Petit asked.

“We haven’t found any evidence that would disprove it,” Hordak spoke up. “And the genetics and technology we share support it.”

That made sense. Of course, that didn’t mean it was true, but Jack’s gut leaned towards agreeing with it. He’d wait for Carter’s assessment, though.

She nodded as well. “It fits all the data we have,” she said, “and the Asgard seem to believe it was true as well, Sir.”

“And yet, while the Asgard claim to oppose the Goa’uld, they refused an alliance,” Sidorov said, scowling. Did he ever smile? Jack didn’t remember seeing the Russian looking happy.

“Thor said they wouldn’t break their treaty with the Goa’uld,” Daniel said. “That would indicate a culture where honour is highly valued.”

“Even if it benefits the Goa’uld and endangers their victims?” General Haig raised his eyebrows.

“It’s possible. An alien species wouldn’t share our values, and past cultures on Earth often put great emphasis on keeping your word.” Daniel pushed his glasses up. “Although, in practice, treaties were often broken when it was convenient.”

“The United States has a history full of such events,” Sidorov said with a scoff.

“Err, yes,” Daniel agreed. “However, we cannot assume that the Asgard act like we would in their place.”

Catra scoffed before Jack could say anything. “If they really cared that much about their honour, they wouldn’t have built death traps for Goa’uld. That’s what you do if you want to stretch the treaty as far as you can without breaking it. I bet that they would find an excuse to break it if they actually wanted to break it.”

Jack nodded. “That’s my impression as well. I think they need the treaty.”

“They have the same technology - more or less - as the Horde,” Hammond said. “And they have had access to it for at least a thousand years. And yet they don’t think that they can defeat the Goa’uld?”

“And you think you can,” Sidorov added, glaring at the Etherians.

“Yes,” Adora nodded firmly. “With the help of our allies, yes.”

“Why would the Asgard disagree?” Li asked.

“We don’t know,” Daniel replied. “If their ethics don’t hold them back, they might have other, more, uh, practical reasons.”

“They might be outnumbered to a degree that makes fighting the Goa’uld too dangerous,” Carter speculated.

“But then, why would the Goa’uld keep the treaty?” Glimmer retorted. “I bet they only made a treaty after conquering the Asgard failed. So they can’t be too weak.”

Jack nodded. That sounded like the snakes.

“Or they weren’t too weak, back then,” Catra said. “And then something changed.”

“They didn’t know Horde Prime, so they couldn’t have been weakened by a conflict with him,” Bow said. “But there must be something…”

Jack nodded. "Thor was hiding something. And they don't have good intel on the Goa'uld."

"One would have expected such people to look for allies," Li said. "And yet, you say they refused to share technology."

"They said they would only share their technology with those who proved themselves mature enough to use it responsibly," Glimmer told him. "And that the decision was up to the High Council."

The generals didn't like that. Jack could tell. He didn't like it either - but he'd like China and Russia having access to advanced technology, more than they already had, even less. Of course, the Asgard might consider Earth advanced or mature enough to share technology… He suppressed a snort. Yeah, right. He didn't need Daniel's opinion to know that that was rather optimistic. Although, if the Asgard valued martial ability, as the epics Daniel told them might hint at, humanity might get a pass.

Not that he'd mention that now, of course. The Etherians would lose all their leverage if Earth got access to Asgard technology.

And Jack was sure that they were aware of that as well.

"It's clear that we need more information about the Asgard. And about the danger Ancient relics might pose to Earth," Hammond said. "I propose to use the next meeting with them to find out more about them."

"That's the obvious course of action," Hordak agreed.

Which, of course, meant that the generals had to debate it.

Jack really missed the old Stargate Command.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 26th, 1998

"...and the senator announced he was resigning effective immediately after a New York Times report uncovered that he had been misusing campaign funds for years to pay for escorts and vacation trips. He declined to answer questions and asked that his family's privacy be respected 'in these trying times', although his wife has been seen boarding a plane to…"

"...der Bundeskanzler beantwortete eine parlamentarische Anfrage dahingehend, dass die Details des Technologietransfers noch nicht festgelegt wurden, aber im Grundsatz…

"...the French Ministre des armées stated that any rumours that the Légion Étrangère was training on the moon were false and clarified that the Légion was training for deployment on other planets, but not on the moon. Further questions were…"

"...Vatican remains silent on the Etherian question, as it has come to be known, but sources close to the Pope claim that the Holy See is expected to release a preliminary statement 'soon'. Neither source was willing to name a date, however, and…"

"...and the situation in Tehran remains volatile. There are no official numbers about the casualties of the latest riot, but the Supreme Leader of Iran confirmed that several 'men with special skills in metaphysics and connections with unknown worlds' were arrested and are currently under investigation. Whether they will be charged for being magicians or spies remains unclear, and…"

"...the FBI has taken over handling a hostage situation in North Dakota. While there was no official statement, local sources confirmed that the hostage situation involved a small religious community and the local sheriff…"

"...Prime Minister of India has lodged a formal protest against the exclusion of India from Stargate Command. The General-Secretary has not yet commented on the issue, but…"

"...riots continue to flare up in various countries in the Middle East while reports about witch hunts in Africa keep growing, and…"

"...Sweden, Denmark, Norway, Finland and Iceland announced their intention to approach the Etherians together and…"

"...the United Nations Security Council announced that Stargate Command has resumed normal operations after being transferred under United Nations control. The United Nations press secretary declined to answer questions about the missions undertaken by the Stargate Teams or whether or not the first non-American team has been deployed already, but…"

Adora shook her head as Catra kept skipping through the tv channels on the bridge of Darla. "Are you even paying attention to the channels?"

"Yes, I am," Catra replied and switched channels again.

"What did the last one say?" Adora asked. She hadn't even managed to catch the broadcasting logo.

"Earth is still a mess. Watch this ad!" Catra leaned back in her seat, craned her head and grinned upside down at her.

Adora frowned. "You couldn't have caught that!"

"And yet, I'm still right!" Catra flashed her fangs.

Well, she likely was correct. Still… Adora pressed her lips together. She knew that this wasn't her fault - the United States had kept aliens and their war with them a secret, knowing that it would cause immense trouble once it got out, and had done so even after the Goa'uld's invasion attempt had almost exposed the whole secret. She also knew that the secret would have come out anyway sooner or later, and revealing it had been both the right thing to do as well as a necessity to wage war. You couldn't lie to your people like that.

But still, she couldn't help feeling guilty about the riots and the deaths, no matter how much she told herself that the humans had been doing that to themselves. They had been killing people for

being witches even though magic had been gone from Earth - and was still gone!

“Hell, no!” Catra exclaimed.

“What?” Adora blinked.

“You’re blaming yourself again!”

Adora clenched her jaws. She couldn’t help it.

“It’s not your fault. There was no good solution. We picked the least bad. It’s not our fault that so many humans are so messed up.

“Still…” Adora trailed off. She didn’t have a better solution. What could she say? “But we could do something. People are dying!”

“What could we do? Invade Iran? Egypt? Most of Africa?” Catra scoffed. She must have paid more attention to Earth geography than Adora had thought.

Adora snorted. Of course she had! Catra just played the lazy cat whenever she liked it, but…

“There you are!” Glimmer frowned at them.

“Where else would we be?” Catra asked.

“In the hold, for the debriefing?” Glimmer scoffed. “Come on!”

“We already had a debriefing,” Catra complained. But she got up anyway.

“That was Stargate Command’s debriefing.” Glimmer turned to head back to the hold.

“I know; I’m just yanking your chain,” Catra said. “Wouldn’t want to discuss sensitive stuff when we’re being recorded by strangers.”

Glimmer didn't turn around, but Adora was sure that she was rolling her eyes.

Catra snorted. "We could have held the debriefing on the bridge."

But Entrapta and Hordak felt more at home in their lab in the hold. And they were the most affected by today's mission. Adora still wasn't sure what she felt about the revelation that Horde Prime had likely been created by an Asgard. Just like Etherians had been created by the First Ones. And if she wasn't sure how to feel about it, Hordak must be even worse off, being directly affected.

"I brought them!" Glimmer announced as they entered the hold. "They were watching television on the bridge."

"Ah. That would have been my second guess if they weren't in their cabin having sex," Entrapta said.

"What?" Adora blinked at her.

"I noticed you like to relax by having sex," Entrapta explained.

Adora felt herself blush. She wasn't ashamed of her love, but…

Catra giggled.

And Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Let's start the debriefing." She took a deep breath. "First, what do you think of the Asgard's claims? About Horde Prime."

"They seem like a valid hypothesis supported by the available data," Entrapta said. "Although we need more data to be certain."

"Yes," Hordak added in a more gravelly voice than usual.

"Eloquent," Catra whispered.

"Yes, but what if it is true?" Glimmer asked. "What do we do?"

Adora blinked. What did she mean?

“Well, then we find out if the Horde fleets are more loyal to Adora and the Alliance than to their family - so to speak,” Catra said.

Ah. That was a possibility, of course. Those clones who felt lost without Horde Prime might very well turn to their ‘ancestors’.

“Would the Asgard even want them?” Bow asked. “They seemed… a bit distant.”

“It would weaken our own position,” Glimmer said. “I don’t think that Priest will leave, but he’s got only one fleet.”

“But the Asgard hate the Goa’uld,” Adora pointed out. “If they lack the numbers to fight them, the clones could tip the balance.”

“And we would lose most of our leverage against Earth.” Glimmer snorted. “If the Asgard had offered their technology, I am sure the humans would have jumped at the opportunity.”

“But we asked for sharing our technology with the Asgard,” Entrapta said. “So…?”

“Yes. But they didn’t share their technology with the Cimmerians. We don’t know if they will share their technology with us, even though we already have comparable technology,” Bow pointed out. “They might not want to share with the humans as long as the treaty holds. That might be too much for the Goa’uld to tolerate. Especially if we already started attacking them.”

“In short, we don’t know enough to make concrete plans,” Catra said, stretching.

“We still can make contingency plans,” Glimmer retorted.

“I think we need a bit more data even for that,” Entrapta said. She cocked her head to look at Hordak.

“We don’t know how and why Horde Prime came into being,” Hordak snorted. “If he was a clone like us, that would be… satisfyingly ironic. A mere clone…”

“You’re not mere anything,” Entrapta told him with a frown.

The two stared at each other, and Adora felt like she was intruding somehow.

Then Glimmer cleared her throat. “So, what do we know about the Asgard?” Adora opened her mouth to answer, but her friend went on: “That we haven’t already mentioned at the debriefing with Stargate Command?”

Adora closed her mouth.

“Nothing but speculation,” Catra said. “They’re hiding something. Something big. And with their hints at Ancient relics being dangerous…” She grimaced.

Adora nodded with a sinking feeling in her stomach. If there was another Heart of Etheria…

She shuddered.

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The Magic Question Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 27th, 1998

"And you saw no possibility to get the 'Asgard' to agree to share their technology with us?"

Samantha Carter didn't frown at the question of General Sidorov even though her report - which she had finished shortly before midnight - answered it succinctly. "No, Sir. Thor made it clear that the decision to share their technology was in the purview of their High Council - presumably their government."

"That's what Dr Jackson also said," General Petit added. "And the Etherians made their offer already."

Entrapta had, but the others hadn't seemed too put off by it.

"Yes. Without any regard for our interests," General Sidorov complained. "And the Etherians didn't state any conditions that the Asgard would have to legalise same-sex marriages!"

"Such conditions would likely be settled during the negotiations of any technology-sharing agreement," General Haig said.

Sam couldn't help feeling that the British officer sounded a little smug. Then again, many British officers tended to sound like him, so it might just be her impression. But the British and the French already had their alliance with the Etherians and they were looking forward to the advanced technology they were about to receive while the United States government was still trying to convince so-called patriots in Congress and state legislatures that the right to discriminate against homosexuals wasn't more important than the ability of the country to defend itself against alien threats.

"Yes," General Petit said. He did sound amused. "Of course, the Asgard might have their own conditions - they didn't share their

advanced technology, or any technology, with the planets under their protection, did they?"

"Not to our knowledge," Sam replied. "And if they are responsible for keeping their protected planets from becoming a threat to the Goa'uld, then they wouldn't uplift the people on those planets."

"They might even sabotage the people under their so-called protection, should they advance past medieval technology." General Sidorov glowered. "We cannot trust them - they were clearly hiding something!"

"I don't know any country that is in the habit of sharing their secrets with strangers," General Li commented. "Except, possibly, for the Etherians." His lips twitched into a small smile.

Sam had to agree - the Etherians were very open about themselves. Arguably, too open - if they had been a bit more discreet about their culture and magic, maybe the reaction on Earth would have been a little less violent. Maybe. Or it might have been seen as an attempt to deceive Earth - people hadn't taken the fact that the United States had kept the Stargate and the war with the Goa'uld secret very well, to say the least.

"It's a ploy!" General Sidorov spat.

Sam was tempted to ask if he meant the Asgard or the Etherians, but refrained from doing so. The Russian officer didn't trust anyone, anyway, so he probably meant both.

"In any case, while the Asgard do not seem to be a threat to Earth or Etheria…" General Hammond said.

"Maybe not an immediate threat, but a threat anyway!" Sidorov interrupted him.

But General Hammond barely reacted to the slight. Sam couldn't help thinking that Hammond's patience and self-control were partially due to the Colonel's attitude. "...we did learn about

potential threats left by the Ancients. Threats supposedly contained - those which are known to the Asgard, at least."

"Yes, Sir," Sam said. Of course, they only had the Asgard's word for that.

"And from what the Etherians have told us about the Heart of Etheria, a weapon of the Ancients, those threats could easily destroy a planet," General Hammond went on.

Or a sector. Sam had seen Entrapta's calculations.

"How much would it take to contain such a threat?" General Li asked.

"Without knowing the nature of the threat, I can't even make a guess," Sam replied. "The Heart of Etheria required direct intervention by Adora, but that was a special situation. Biological weapons might require quarantining a planet, which could require quite the resources." Or sterilising the planet. That was a theoretical option for Earth, but Sam thought that the Etherians and the Asgard would be able to do it. Not that she would mention it to Entrapta.

"Could such a commitment be what is keeping the Asgard from fighting the Goa'uld?" General Haig asked.

Sam inclined her head. "It's possible." They had considered that last night. But they didn't know enough to tell. We need more data, Sam thought, hearing it in Entrapta's voice.

"But we cannot say it with any certainty." General Haig nodded. "It's a little unnerving to know that such threats might be more common than we hoped."

General Petit chuckled at the understatement while General Sidorov kept glowering.

"We can't do anything about that for now, so I think we should focus on what we can do," General Hammond said.

“Exactly. We need to identify the other protected planets - and find out if the Asgard were telling us the truth about them,” General Sidorov said.

“We have a list of the gate addresses,” Sam pointed out. “And we matched them to systems.” Which had taken her past midnight. She really needed more computing power.

“The Asgard didn’t prohibit visits, so we should send teams to check those addresses,” General Li said. “We need more information.”

“But not SG-1,” General Hammond said. “We cannot risk losing Teal’c - we have to assume they have such defence systems on every planet they protect.”

“And, possibly, orbital defences,” Sam added. “We need better sensor gear so we can check on a mission.”

“Wouldn’t orbital defences be hidden from sensors? As much as that is possible, anyway,” General Haig said.

Sam nodded. “Yes. But a magically enhanced sensor might penetrate the Asgard’s stealth systems.” Entrapta hadn’t had any trouble checking their technology on the ground, after all.

General Sidorov scoffed again, but the others nodded. “That requires the cooperation of the Etherians,” General Li noted.

“At least until Magic is restored to Earth,” General Petit said. “And we can train our own wizards.” He grinned.

Sam thought the officer was a bit too optimistic. Training sorcerers would take years. And Etherian help.

And magic had to be restored first. Sam still wasn’t sure how she felt about that.

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Whitehall, Westminster, London, United Kingdom, Earth, September 28th, 1998

"...and here's how we plan to keep the information secure. We're using multiple layers of…"

Catra tuned the British intelligence officer doing the presentation out and looked at the files they had been given. It seemed to be a decent setup. A good mix between secure procedures and common sense - the factories had to be able to produce stuff without jumping through hoops, after all. Certainly better protected from spies than the usual horde factory.

But the real target wouldn't be factories but the people working in them - especially those who knew how to build advanced technology. She flipped through the folder, not caring how Adora frowned at her for obviously ignoring the presentation, and read up on how they tackled that. Ah. Strict surveillance of the engineers. And… She blinked. "A tracking device"?

Everyone stared at her as the officer stopped talking about sensors and patrols. "Err, yes. All crucial people with the highest clearance will be required to wear a tracking device so we can check their position at all times. We still encourage protection details and guarded housing, of course."

And so they could keep them under surveillance. Well, it was important to keep the technology out of the hands of hostile countries. And as far as Catra was concerned, a lot of the countries on Earth were hostile. She certainly didn't want countries where it was illegal for her to love Adora to get access to advanced technology. Hell, she was still wary of the United States after all she had seen of their conservative politicians.

At least most of the countries that couldn't be trusted didn't have the means to spy on their allies - with the notable exceptions of Russia and China. And those had access to the Stargate, which meant they wouldn't just be hunting for advanced technology like

the Americans had been but would also have excuses for stolen technology turning up in their hands.

"Well, if they agree to that…" Adora looked like she wasn't entirely on board with that.

"It's for their own safety," the officer pointed out.

"Not everyone wants to be under permanent surveillance," Bow pointed out.

"It's strictly volunteer-only," the officer replied.

Of course, the chances for a scientist to get to work with advanced technology without agreeing to that wouldn't be high, Catra was sure.

"Any other comments?" the British admiral in the meeting asked.

Catra made a point of thinking for a moment, cocking her head, before answering: "No."

And the meeting continued.

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"We really should hold those meetings together with the other countries," Catra said as the meeting had finally ended and they left the room. "We're going through three times the meetings otherwise."

"I've suggested it," Glimmer said. "But, apparently, each country's situation is different."

"I thought they were in the defence alliance," Catra mumbled. "But if we held them in space, they'd agree!"

"Probably." Bow grinned.

"I would certainly be in favour," the British admiral told them with a smile. "Although I do have to agree that the political situation in

our allied countries is too different to combine such meetings."

"Great," Catra muttered. "We'll be dying from paperwork and old age before we get this war really going." She hadn't had to deal with so many meetings in the Horde. Not that that meant the Horde had been a good place. Still…

"Well, at least we got things straightened out," the admiral went on. "And the technological transfer should be able to commence on schedule."

"Yes!" Entrapta smiled. "And the Americans are making progress as well."

That didn't please the British officers, Catra noticed, though they kept smiling politely.

"It would facilitate things," Adora said. "It's already complicated with the Stargate controlled by the United Nations."

"Well," the general representing the British Army - which, for some weird historical reason, wasn't the Royal Army, unlike their Navy and Air Force - said, "If the United States joined the Alliance, members would have a majority in Stargate Command."

"Small mercies," the admiral commented with a chuckle. Apparently, they still carried grudges. "So, what's next on your schedule?"

"After the meetings with France and Germany about the same things we just discussed? A meeting with the United Nations regarding magic," Glimmer told him.

"Ah." The admiral nodded. "That is bound to be lively."

That must be the British understatement Catra had heard about. She shrugged. "Well, it's not as if they can outlaw magic."

"Last I heard, several countries have proposed a resolution doing exactly that," the general cut in.

"So?" Catra cocked her head at him. "How many such resolutions have been ignored so far?"

"If the United Nations Security Council actually passes a resolution, there's the question of whether or not such a resolution would be actually binding for us since we're not a country on Earth," Glimmer added. "Although it would be already a stretch to consider magic a threat to peace."

Glimmer must have studied the United Nations, Catra realised. Well, better her than Catra.

"So your stance is that magic doesn't fall under Chapter VII of the UN Charter?" the admiral asked.

"Yes." Glimmer nodded. "They might not agree, but even so - what are the odds that all permanent members of the Security Council will support such a resolution? The Americans still haven't sorted out what they think about magic."

"Well, they're in a bind."

More chuckling followed, but it sounded a little forced.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 28th, 1998

Jack O'Neill suppressed the sudden and stupid urge to hum the melody of 'Monday Morning' when he approached the training field. Colonels didn't break out into a song as if life was a musical. Surely not when they came to check on how the training of the new guys was going.

And, on the off-chance that she knew Fleetwood Mac, he didn't want to give Lenkova any ideas. 'Monday morning you sure look fine' was more than a little suggestive, especially seen through the eyes of a Russian spy likely trained as a honey trap.

And as a special forces soldier, he reminded himself when he saw her squad was training in hand-to-hand combat. And doing better than most. Of course, he already knew that from her bout with Teal'c.

He looked at the rest of the field as he walked over to Major Warren, who was in charge for today.

"Sir!" Warren saluted.

Jack returned the salute, a little surprised. They usually weren't as formal, even if half the new guys were watching. Or especially - Jack didn't want to see Stargate Command turned into a unit where forms were more important than results, and the divide between enlisted and officers was too deep. That wouldn't work too well in the field, and Jack would hate it at the base. Saluting the foreign generals every time you saw them was bad enough.

But he wasn't here to complain about the brass. "So, how are they doing?" he asked, watching another squad go at it.

"As well as can be expected. Our new allies didn't send the worst of their forces." Warren frowned a little. "They learn quickly. Still wouldn't want to send them through the gate on their own any time soon," he added.

"Not even to a known location?" Jack tilted his head slightly. They had some 'baby's first Stargate' addresses to ease new guys into travelling the galaxy.

"Maybe the empty ones," Warren said.

Ah. Jack nodded. He wouldn't want to let the new guys loose on unsuspecting populations on alien planets. Especially not the Russians and Chinese - if they didn't have orders to acquire any advanced technology they could, no matter how, he'd eat his service cap. Just imagining what they would have done if faced with Thor made him want to curse. The only thing worse would have been the NID meeting Thor. The Asgard would have probably declared war on Earth in that case.

He watched the training for a few minutes. All of the teams had a good grounding in hand-to-hand combat, far better than regular soldiers - but he knew that already. And they were learning fast, as Warren had said.

His eyes caught Lenkova right after she smashed one of her team members into the ground, and the Russian spy smiled at him. Slyly. As if she had caught him at something inappropriate instead of watching the training. She was one of the most dangerous new guys, after all. Girls. Whatever. Jack made a point to watch the squad next to hers for a while.

"Have you heard anything about joint missions, Colonel?" Warren asked in a low voice after a few minutes.

The middle of training wasn't the best moment to spread rumours and fish for information, and Warren would know that. If he was asking anyway, he must be really concerned about something. Jack shrugged. "I haven't heard anything. They deployed us with SG-2, but that was mostly because we're friends with the Etherians." And none of the nations running the new Stargate Command wanted to annoy the aliens. "Of course, joint missions will either be very good for our unit cohesion or make us shoot each other no matter who gets to team up with whom." Someone even suggested splitting up all teams and forming new ones - mixed ones including forces from all nations. Fortunately for the fool, by the time Jack had heard about this nonsense - splitting up SG-1? Over his dead body! - the idea had been shot down by everyone else already. As if he'd let his team be split up. Or put experienced team members under the command of a new guy. Or girl.

"I see, Sir." Warren sounded as relieved as Jack had felt. After a moment, he added: "I've heard from a few old friends, Sir. They've been called up to head units training for deployment off-world. Expeditionary units."

"Someone's optimistic about our politicians," Jack commented. They would need an alliance with the Etherians to field Marines in

those numbers.

"Yes, Sir."

Well, they might not be overly optimistic - the newspapers and TV pundits were hammering the conservative holdouts hard. Almost all of them, at least; some extremists were still ranting about godless aliens corrupting the American youth. But it looked like both public opinion and politics were shifting.

After a moment, Warren glanced at his watch and yelled: "Alright! Break for five!"

The squads on the field stopped hitting each other and headed to the break area, where the drinks and snacks were stored. None of them lingered to exchange a few more blows, Jack noted.

He and Warren watched them go before heading over themselves. Officers ate last, after all.

But when Jack approached the chow line, Lenkova joined him. He stopped and gestured, letting her go before him, and she smiled.

"An officer and a gentleman?"

"Didn't really like the movie," he replied. He was an Air Force officer; liking romances about a naval aviator came straight after 'dereliction of duty' in the 'things you aren't allowed to do in the Air Force' regulations.

"Movie?" She cocked her head at him.

Jack berated himself. He shouldn't have quipped; that only gave the spy an in. Well, it wasn't the first time his mouth got him into trouble. "It's a movie with Richard Gere about a romance between a Navy pilot candidate and a factory worker," he explained as they reached the snack box.

"Ah. A male officer and a working-class woman?" She sounded… well, not mocking, but there was a hint of disapproval. Or

amusement.

Jack suppressed the urge to point out that back at the start of the eighties, movies featuring a female officer and a male factory worker wouldn't have sold. Not that he thought they'd sell today, either. "Yes," he said instead.

"And you didn't like it?" She wasn't dropping the topic.

"It was about a *Navy* pilot," he said.

"Ah. Service rivalry." She nodded, then grabbed a coke and a Snickers. "I've heard of it. Is it true that service rivalry is fostered by the government so they can have one branch shoot the other if they need to make an example?"

Jack smiled as sweetly as he could as he replied: "Well, without the NKVD, we have to make do."

She laughed at that. It was even a nice laugh, and her smile seemed genuine. "Your humour is almost Russian, Colonel."

That was probably meant to be a compliment. "Thank you," he said.

Then he heard Warren chuckle behind him and wanted to curse himself. And Lenkova.

Who was drinking her coke as if she were in a commercial where she was wearing a bikini instead of a striped t-shirt under Russian fatigues, with her back arched to emphasise her chest.

Well, there was no helping it - the rumour mill would grind on now. Jack grabbed a Mars bar and a coke for himself.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, September 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and why should we allow magic to return to Earth? It goes against our religion! It will destabilise society! Corrupt the youth! My country - the world - is still reeling from the revelation that aliens are real, with riots happening daily, and you want to introduce another shock? The United Nations need to take a stand and ban the practice!"

Adora frowned. That was the third ambassador in a row that wanted Earth - well, the United Nations - to ban magic. Or ban the return of magic.

The ambassador from India rose. Wasn't he supposed to wait until he was recognised? But the debate had grown more and more heated, and this was supposed to be an informational meeting with Adora and her friends. Maybe the rules were different here. "Magic is an important part of my country's religion. To ban magic would be an unacceptable violation of our religious freedom - and a blatant attempt to force your views and culture on us! India has not fought for her freedom from colonialist powers only to bow to them again!"

"You dare to call out others as colonialists when you attempt to force such evil on your own people?" Another glared at India's ambassador.

Adora checked the plate. Right. Pakistan and India had a violent history - she had learned that preparing for this meeting.

"The vast majority of our people want magic, our ancestors' legacy, restored to us. We won't let a minority oppress us just as we won't let foreigners oppress us!"

"But you want to force magic on the entire world - as a minority!" Pakistan's ambassador countered. A lot of ambassadors loudly voiced their support.

"No one forces you to practise magic!" the Indian shot back once things had calmed down a little. "You are free to ban it in your

countries - you already have, after all, even though magic was taken from us a thousand years ago," he added with a sneer.

"It was taken from Earth with good reason! Magic is dangerous - it corrupts people!"

And if weaponised, it could blow up a sector. But that was a very special case.

"You're overreacting," Glimmer spoke up. "Magic is no more dangerous than technology."

"And we limit and ban dangerous technology! Like nuclear weapons!" Pakistan's ambassador exclaimed.

"That's rich coming from a country with nuclear weapons!" another ambassador - oh, that was Bangladesh - said.

"We do not proliferate the technology!"

"Wanna bet whether they go to war over this?" Catra whispered next to her. Not even she sounded amused, though.

Glimmer clenched her teeth and stood, her hands not quite slamming down on the table. "Listen! You keep talking about how magic is dangerous, but you have no idea what magic is! Don't you realise how… weird this looks?"

"You don't know what Earth magic will look like either! You said so yourself!" the man from Iran said with a deep sneer.

Adora frowned at him. He had openly called for executing 'witches' - and while he hadn't said it out loud, he had left no doubt he thought this should include Adora and her friends.

"That's because every planet's magic is unique," Glimmer pointed out. "It depends on your traditions. But no matter what your traditions are, you can't just do magic. You need to study how to work magic. And you need a talent for magic."

“And when you’ve done all that? What will stop a witch from cursing everyone?” Another of the African ambassadors scoffed. They were the majority of the countries backing a ban on magic, Adora knew.

“What is stopping anyone from taking a weapon and killing people?” Glimmer shook her head. “Magic isn’t any different than technology. You can deal with it.”

“It only requires sorcerers of your own,” the British ambassador said.

That didn’t placate the others at all - quite the contrary. It grew even louder in the room.

Once more, it took a little while until things calmed down enough so people could be heard again.

“You know, if Alliance meetings were like this, they would be a lot more entertaining,” Catra whispered to her.

Adora frowned at her in response before listening to the Brazilian ambassador. “This is not merely a question of whether or not our religion prohibits magic, but of the danger magic represents. Imagine terrorists using magic to strike at their targets! How can you defend against a curse? No one would be safe! Many such attacks might not even be noticed if the victim merely suffers a fatal accident or illness!”

“If the attack doesn’t get noticed, it’s not terrorism!” someone cut in. “Spreading terror is the point of terrorism! You’re talking about assassinations!”

“Whatever!” the Brazilian went on. “Imagine this power in the hands of insurgents! No government would be safe! We would be held hostage by extremists! For the good of us all, we need to ban magic!”

Adora heard Catra curse under her breath. She could understand the feeling - this argument was swaying people.

Once more, Glimmer spoke up. “Magic can protect you against magic!”

Another ambassador yelled: “At the cost of our souls!”

“Magic isn’t evil just as technology isn’t evil,” Glimmer retorted. “Both can be abused. And as events on Earth have shown, even if you ban magic, you aren’t safe from magitech.”

Like the zombie plague generator, as Jack had called it. Adora nodded firmly.

“So, by banning magic, you would cripple your defences against it without being safe.” Glimmer scoffed.

“What’s magitech?” someone else asked.

“Magitech is advanced technology using magic effects but powered by non-magical sources,” Bow explained. “You do not need to have magic restored on a planet to use it.”

“Let’s ban magitech!”

Catra rolled her eyes and spoke up. “You think you can ban that technology? And win the war against the Goa’uld?” She scoffed. “Really, you should be demanding magic be restored as soon as possible since most of you will have a much easier time getting magic to work for you than getting our advanced technology, especially the way you’re acting.”

Adora frowned - it would still take quite a lot of work to get a decent number of sorcerers in a country. You couldn’t just snap your finger and do magic - it took years of study. But Glimmer was smiling as she nodded, and a number of the ambassadors had suddenly fallen silent.

“So that’s why you want magic restored!” the ambassador from Pakistan yelled at India’s ambassador. “You plan to attack us with it!”

“India has no plans to attack anyone!” the Indian shot back. “But yes, we are counting on magic to improve our country without having to be dependent on foreign powers. It’s our heritage.”

A number of ambassadors still protested, especially the ones from the Middle East countries, as far as Adora could tell, but several others who had vocally opposed magic were suddenly silent.

“Look how their concerns just vanished,” Catra muttered with a grin.

Adora had to agree - but she also had to admit that the Brazilian had a point about the danger magic represented for those who had no defence against it. And yet… She was surprised how quickly religious concerns were brushed aside by so many, after everything that she had heard and seen before. “I guess it’s really all about power,” she whispered.

“Always was,” Catra said.

It was hard to disagree with her as the discussion took a turn towards the practicability of magical education on Etheria.

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“...and while our sorcerers can teach others, provided they have the talent, any students would be learning Etheria’s traditions, not Earth’s magical traditions,” Glimmer explained for the second time.

“But your traditions do not teach people how to conjure evil spirits or make bargains with demons,” an ambassador retorted. “Unlike magic here.”

“None of our magical traditions require either!” India’s ambassador cut in. He had been doing that a lot, together with the Japanese ambassador.

“So you claim! We know better!”

“Leaving religious disagreements aside,” the Swedish ambassador spoke up, “We do have to consider that by relying on a foreign magical education, we might strangle our own cultural and magical heritage.”

“That should be any country’s decision,” the ambassador from Liberia shot back.

“Of course. I was merely pointing out that this should require further consideration.”

“Says the ambassador from a country that is asking for access to advanced technology.”

“That has no bearing on the question of magical traditions and heritage,” the Swede retorted.

“On the contrary! That’s a crucial aspect of the entire question!”

“They’re talking as if they can just send hundreds of people to Etheria to get trained,” Glimmer muttered. “I’ve told them that Mystacor isn’t an open university and that they would decide whom they would train!”

Catra leaned over, her head in front of Adora’s chest, to answer Glimmer: “They’re a little hard of hearing.”

Adora had to agree once more. At least, it seemed that the resolution to ban magic from Earth - or ban its return - was no longer a concern, even though several countries still were pushing for it. Although as far as she knew, most of those ambassadors would have to check with their governments before making any binding statements or votes.

So the question of whether or not Adora should return magic at the request of India and Japan hadn’t been answered. Sure, if the United Nations didn’t ban magic, it would follow that it was allowed to restore magic to Earth. But if Adora had learned one thing from all the meetings of the Alliance and now on Earth, it was that politics were rarely logical.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, September 29th, 1998

"....and in the General Assembly of the United Nations, the topic of a ban on magic continues to be hotly debated as tensions between Pakistan and India are rising. The Arab League has announced their full support of Pakistan in this growing conflict and reaffirmed their intent to ban all magic, though support for the stance is wavering amongst many African nations. The European Union released a statement that affirmed the right of any nation to decide their internal policies provided they did not violate human rights but didn't elaborate on whether or not they considered the restoration of magic to be covered by this. According to anonymous sources, several South and Central American member states have voiced reservations concerning magic on religious grounds, although this may change with the release of the Vatican's statement later today - an announcement which many experts expect to cover the Catholic Church's stance on magic, and…"

Samantha Carter switched the television off. She had heard the news twice already, and it hadn't changed significantly - the hosts and pundits were just growing more and more excited without anything to justify it.

She put the remote down and resisted the urge to stretch her arms over her head - it was barely mid-morning, and she didn't want to give the impression that she hadn't slept well or long enough. Especially not when both were true.

Although, she added to herself, Daniel doesn't look like he'd notice. Her friend had his nose buried in an older tome he had brought into her lab.

"Fascinating. I never really delved into all the various magical traditions in Europe; not my speciality, and it wasn't really relevant for our work - not until we met the Etherians, in any case,

although some of it might give us insights into handling those Goa'uld using European myths as their cover. But with the Goa'uld using technology, I never really cared about the potential of actual magic. Just imagine if we could get the divination rituals of ancient Rome to work!"

Sam wasn't an expert on ancient history, but she had gone through college and the Air Force Academy, and she had worked with Daniel for a long time now, so… "You mean reading the future in the entrails of a sacrificed animal?"

"Ah, yes. Amongst other rituals," Daniel looked sheepish. "This would be messy, wouldn't it? Although if we could get the cooperation of a butcher, given how much meat we eat, it shouldn't be too hard to arrange a few experiments…"

"You would also need to find people with the talent for magic," she pointed out. The Etherians had been clear about that, and the data they had gathered at Research Site Alpha confirmed it: Not everyone could work magic.

"Right." He frowned. "Finding them might be a problem unless we can isolate the gene for magic talent." He looked at her with a hopeful smile.

"I'm no geneticist," she told him. "But, as far as I know, there are research projects working on identifying the Ancient gene." It was only logical after the revelation of the Colonel's ancestry, after all.

"Oh! Do you think Jack has magic potential? The Ancients - or First Ones - were working with magic, after all. And manipulated the Etherian genetics."

She pressed her lips together. Although the Colonel had never said anything about it, other than some off-colour jokes, she knew he wasn't happy about that particular revelation. And she didn't think he would like learning magic either. "We don't know enough about Ancients to know," she said.

"Right. Well, I hope we'll soon know more. With everyone preparing to jumpstart magic projects, it's bound to lead to some results." He nodded.

"Or to a debacle," Sam retorted. "If countries start identifying potential sorcerers through their genes…" She trailed off.

Daniel gasped. "Literal witch hunts using DNA testing!"

Sam nodded. Forced conscription of people with magic talents was the mildest problem she could imagine. But in those countries where 'witchcraft' was a capital crime, things would be much, much worse once magic was returned to Earth.

"Are the Etherians aware of that?" Daniel asked.

Sam sighed. "I don't know if they considered this." Sometimes, their friends were quite naive. Or just inexperienced with Earth's cultures and practices. Entrapta was both, of course.

"We need to tell them!" Daniel said. "They can't just return magic if it means people getting murdered for their ancestry."

People had been getting murdered for their ancestry for millennia, all over the world. And people were getting murdered for being called witches even with magic still absent from Earth. But Sam didn't say that. True as it might be, it wasn't relevant. "I don't think they can test for a gene. We don't even know what the gene or genes for magical talent is. We don't even know if it's tied to the Ancient heritage - and Colonel O'Neill's ancestry isn't exactly public knowledge either." Sure, with Stargate Command being transferred under the control of the United Nations Security Council, foreign countries had access to their files. But only Russia, China, Britain and France. Stargate Command hadn't been able to justify hiding the Colonel's special heritage, not when it could be revealed as soon as he walked into another Ancient facility. But the countries most likely to attempt to 'purge' witches wouldn't have access to that data. "People lack sufficient data to test for witches," she added. Of course, that might change if

magic was restored and people started expressing a talent for it. She had to mention that to the Etherians.

"Right. But are we testing for the Ancient gene?" Daniel asked. "If we know it, of course - how close do you think we are to identifying it?"

"So far, we only know of two people who are descendants of Ancients: The Colonel and Adora," Sam said. "Without access to more samples, it will be hard to identify people with the same ancestry." They didn't have a sample of Adora. At least, Sam hoped no one had been as stupid as to steal a sample of her.

"There's his family," Daniel pointed out. "His extended family, I mean." He blinked. "Oh. Maybe… No. Too far-fetched."

Sam frowned. "What is too far-fetched, Daniel?"

"Nothing!" Daniel replied. Sam raised her eyebrows, and he caved. "I just wondered if Lieutenant Lenkova was less of a honey trap and more of a… family trap? Maybe the Russians want a child of Jack to compare genes? Ridiculous, I know!" He laughed - a little forcedly.

Sam clenched her jaws. It was ridiculous. Obviously so. The Colonel wouldn't… well, the odds of such a scheme working were so small as to be nonexistent. And they didn't know if it was even planned.

But she still felt the urge to test a few of her recent inventions on a certain Russian officer.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, September 29th, 1998

"...and that was a bombshell, wasn't it? Who would have expected this from the Pope? I certainly didn't! Terry?"

"Well, I'd say that nobody expects the Spanish Inquisition, but I did. To claim that magic is part of God's creation and inherently neutral, not evil, that witches can be good Christians as long as they don't use their magic for evil goes against centuries of history!"

"Indeed, Terry! But we have an expert on the Vatican here, Dr Marconi. Dr Marconi, what do you say to this shocking development?"

"Well, Mr Smith, first, the Pope's declaration doesn't go against centuries of tradition. The Catholic Church's stance towards witches has never been as hostile as people claim - in fact, for centuries, the Church prohibited witch hunts! It was only after the protestant movement took off that witch hunts were conducted by the Church, and even then, they remained rare in the solidly Catholic countries. The infamous Spanish Inquisition, for example, despite popular myths, wasn't aimed at witches but at so-called heretics and 'hidden jews'. So, this declaration is not violating Church dogma - though, of course, the summoning of spirits and similar creatures has been explicitly restricted. So, today's declaration is no surprise for those who know the history and dogma of the Catholic Church. In fact, now that we know that magic was taken from Earth roughly a thousand years ago, the Church's stance back then that there were no witches has been confirmed, which has several interesting implications. And one cannot forget that the Catholic Church has proven to be very pragmatic and able to adapt to changing circumstances. I would actually focus on the first part as surprising - the Pope outright stated that aliens have souls. That is a revolutionary declaration I didn't expect, certainly not as explicitly. This has far greater effects on…"

Catra yawned as the 'expert' went into more details she didn't care for. "So, magic isn't evil unless you use it for evil, and we have souls. How shocking!" She scoffed as she leaned back in her seat and craned her head to look at the others.

“It is shocking for a lot of people, according to the news reports,” Bow pointed out. “Obviously, they expected the Pope to condemn us.”

“The Pope doesn’t want to alienate us,” Glimmer said with a grin - probably proud of her pun. But she quickly frowned.

“It’s still a good thing.” Adora smiled. “That’s a lot of people who won’t see us as evil now!”

Bow cleared his throat. “Well… He didn’t say anything about homosexuality. And only the Catholics are listening to him, and not even all of them. Some are already claiming that he must be corrupt. Or possessed.”

Catra scoffed again. “Typical! If you don’t like a decision, attack your superior!”

“Well, they are responsible,” Adora retorted. “But in this case, aren’t they supposed to follow his rules?”

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “In theory. But going against the Pope is a big thing, so this should help with the acceptance of magic.”

Almost as much as the realisation that magic could give any country an advantage helped. Catra shook her head. “So what? It won’t really affect us anyway.” It wasn’t as if they were going to listen to the idiots calling magic evil, anyway.

“The more people, especially religious people, accept magic, the better,” Adora insisted. “That means the United Nations won’t ban magic.”

Catra shrugged. The odds of any such resolution not being defeated by a veto at the latest had been zero already before this, anyway. “So, are you going to restore magic now?”

“Uh…” Adora sighed and lowered her head. “I want to, and the Indians keep pushing for it. And the Japanese.” Which also were pushing for a diplomatic meeting about advanced technology,

Catra knew. “But with what Sam told us…” Adora pressed her lips together.

Catra nodded. Witch hunts based on your genes - your ancestry. People getting killed for… for simply existing. Well, the same people already wanted to kill her for loving Adora, and anyone else who loved the same sex.

“That would be genocide,” Glimmer said. “A crime against humanity. The United Nations would intervene.”

“Are we sure of that?” Bow asked. “They didn’t intervene in the past.”

“Well, they should know that we would intervene if they don’t,” Glimmer said.

“We would?” Catra’s ears twitched. She wouldn’t mind crushing those fools who threatened her and Adora, but… “What about not interfering with other countries?”

Glimmer huffed. “This is an exception, of course.”

“But they are already killing witches!” Adora protested. “Well, people they claim are witches. Why don’t we stop them?”

“Because that’s a crime, but not a genocide,” Glimmer said. “And it’s not the country that is doing it, but parts of the population. We don’t attack a kingdom for what bandits are doing.”

“Not unless the princess is sponsoring and using the bandits.” Catra grinned.

Glimmer frowned at her. “Yes, of course, there are exceptions. But they don’t even know yet how to look for sorcerers with tests. So, that’s not going to happen anyway.”

“But once the magic is back, they’ll be able to find sorcerers by looking for magic being done,” Bow pointed out. “Anyone displaying magic powers would be a target.”

"Just like anyone whom people don't like is currently a target," Catra retorted. "And was a target before." People would get hurt and killed anyway under any pretext.

"But if I return magic, any deaths that happen will be on my head," Adora said glumly.

Catra rolled her eyes, then reached over and smacked the back of Adora's head. "Stop being an idiot! Those people are already hunting 'witches', and they won't stop. They don't care that there's no magic around yet. And sooner or later, they'll get that test for magic talents. You're not saving anyone by keeping magic away - you're just ensuring that they won't be able to defend themselves."

"Well, technically…" Bow trailed off at Catra's glare. "I didn't say anything!"

"Catra's right," Glimmer said, and Catra preened. "It's not your fault. And Earth deserves to get its magic back. The entire planet without magic? It's unnatural."

Catra nodded. "And you don't give in to those people. They won't stop anyway." They were going for people like her and Adora already, magic or no magic. You couldn't placate them.

"And we need to restore magic to planets we invade anyway, so we can use our powers," Glimmer added.

"But there'll be trouble and more riots on Earth if magic is returned," Bow pointed out.

Catra rolled her eyes. "As opposed to right now? Better to ride that stuff out now, instead of when we're fighting the Goa'uld on multiple fronts."

Adora slowly nodded.

*****

The Magic Question Part 2

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 1st, 1998

"...and that's about it."

Jack O'Neill blinked at Glimmer. Those had been quite a number of words for something simple. "So… you want to get the United Nations to declare open season on genocidal countries?"

Judging by the way Catra grinned, Daniel frowned and Carter pressed her lips together, he had hit the right amount of levity for such a topic.

Glimmer frowned as well. "Not 'open season'. We just want to ensure that the United Nations know that we're ready to intervene if a country should start a genocide. Of course, it should be obvious that we wouldn't stand by in such a case."

Well, they had been sending mixed signals if they thought this would be obvious, in Jack's opinion. "There are already witch hunts going on," he pointed out - diplomatically. The Etherians hadn't intervened in those.

"Not organised by any state," Glimmer said. "As far as we know."

But likely tolerated. Then again, the last thing Earth needed was a bunch of aliens with a space fleet playing world police.

And, of course, Daniel hadn't gotten that memo. "But there are several states where witchcraft is a capital crime."

"Yes." Glimmer pressed her lips together. "But since magic hasn't been restored to Earth, there aren't any actual sorceresses on Earth yet."

"With the exception of you," Catra added as she fiddled with one of the plaques on the table.

Well, better a broken plaque than some broken gadget in Carter's lab.

"I'd like to see them try to try me," Glimmer said with a sneer. Then she sighed. "Yes, we're aware of that. But as long as such countries don't actually start killing people for having a magical talent…" She shrugged. "We don't want to interfere with other countries."

Jack nodded even though he could think of quite a few countries which deserved to be interfered with.

"But as long as they know that we won't tolerate such things, they should know better than to do it," Adora said.

"But once people know where the, ah, red line is," Daniel said, "they know how far they can go - and likely will go as far. So, by stating you'll intervene if a genocide starts, you also state that you won't intervene if it's not a genocide."

"That does not follow," Teal'c pointed out. "Unless stated outright, nothing prevents Etheria from intervening without a genocide taking place."

"Like the United States' stance towards our defence commitment towards Taiwan," Carter said.

"I don't think that policy is a good idea in this case," Jack retorted. "The countries where witches are being hunted aren't as rational as the Chinese. Which, by the way, will probably grow a little anxious if you're vague, what with their policy in Tibet."

Glimmer winced. "Yes. We're aware of that issue. We… don't wish to get involved in such cases."

Ah. Jack couldn't help grinning a little - and showing his teeth. "Only clear cases of 'let's kill those people' qualify as genocide, right?"

That earned him a glare from almost everyone.

“Jack! We’re talking about military intervention here!” Daniel blurted out.

Glimmer, though, met his eyes. “Yes. We don’t want to start a war over… cultural issues. Not unless they lead to people getting killed for their ancestry.”

“We probably would have to declare war on everyone on Earth if we did that,” Catra said with a snort.

Adora glared at her, then sighed as well. “Yes. We don’t want to start a war even though we don’t like what is happening in Tibet and elsewhere.”

Jack had no doubt that Adora hated to restrain herself. She wasn’t the type to do ‘Realpolitik’.

“Well, if you wait for the United Nations to call something out as genocide, the Chinese won’t have to worry about being put on the spot,” Jack said.

“We’re aware of that as well,” Glimmer said. “But that’s your system.”

“And unless the system breaks and the mass graves and gas chambers start up again, you’re not going to break it.” Jack nodded. Sensible, but it did leave a bad taste in your mouth - worse, of course, if you had the power to actually do something about it.

“Yes.” Glimmer took a deep breath. “We also hope that things will improve in several countries as a result of our alliances and our presence, but that will take a while.”

Adora nodded, as did Daniel, almost eagerly. Jack tried to hide his cynicism. He didn’t think things would improve as the Etherians hoped. Or some of them - Catra didn’t look as if she thought things would magically improve.

Heh, ‘magically’! Jack snorted. “Yeah, sounds like you’ve got this thought out.”

“Kind of,” Bow spoke up. “We wanted a second opinion from someone we trust.” He smiled at Jack and the others. Adora positively beamed.

And Jack suppressed the urge to curse. He didn’t like being put on the spot like this. It was worse since everyone was so sincere, so trusting towards him - and so much was at stake. He glanced at Catra, who grinned at him. The damn catwoman knew what he was feeling.

And, of course, his team was letting him take the lead here. Even Daniel, who could usually be trusted to speak up before anyone else could stop him.

Jack sighed. “Well…” What to say? And how to word it? He wasn’t exactly a politician. Or a diplomat. “It’s a touchy issue,” he said. “And every situation is unique.”

“You mean some situations get the veto, and others don’t,” Catra cut in unhelpfully. That was Jack’s role, damn it!

He narrowed his eyes and crossed his arms. “If you say you’re following the United Nations lead and rules, are you going to stick to it? Even when a case of genocide gets vetoed?”

The way the Etherians exchanged glances, that wasn’t a given.

“One could claim that a country stepping in like that to prevent an intervention is helping to commit a genocide,” Glimmer said.

That was… well, it wasn’t a bad argument, Jack had to admit. One he’d make himself - hell, why was he arguing in favour of following orders he knew were wrong again? Right, to keep the Etherians from taking over. “And what if the other countries don’t agree with that interpretation?”

“Would they?” Catra’s ears twitched. “Wouldn’t they like to gang up on such a country?”

“You’d be surprised.” Jack shrugged. “No one wants to be the next one up on the wall.”

“I thought that was the purpose of the United Nations.” Bow frowned. “To ensure the crimes against humanity wouldn’t happen again.”

“Yep,” Jack said. “But the great powers wanted a little insurance so the weaker countries couldn’t enforce their rules on them.”

Adora scowled at that. “If rules don’t apply to everyone, what good are they?”

Jack grinned. “Well, that’s the question, right?”

Oh, the glare she sent at him for having her words twisted back at her.

“Well…” Daniel must have finally reached his limit. “The question of what to do if a law or rule has been deemed unfair or unjust is a very old question. What if breaking the law does even more harm? There’s the fact that any law that’s not enforced weakens the entire system, although that’s more abstract, and then there’s the cost of any intervention. You need not only to remove the government but replace it. And there might be resistance to the new regime. Violent resistance. Coups and regime changes rarely were bloodless. When exactly is it justified to break the law? When someone guilty would escape justice? Or when someone innocent would be punished?”

“When someone would be killed for being born,” Adora snapped. “You can’t obey a law that defends such a crime!”

“I don’t think that’s going to be an issue,” Carter told her. “Any country pursuing such a policy would be a pariah.”

Jack agreed - if only because no one would want to provoke the Etherians like that.

"But what about displacing a native population? Attacking their culture?" Daniel shook his head. "It's a lot harder to judge such cases."

"You mean that 'cultural imperialism' people accuse us of?" Catra asked. She scoffed.

"Yes." Daniel nodded. "A considerable number of countries feels that an attempt to enforce global human rights on them is imperialism in another form." He frowned, "Although it is kind of ironic that when it comes to the discrimination of homosexuality, many countries are now defending the values originally forced on them by colonial powers as their own."

"That's stupid," Adora commented. "And it doesn't matter anyway - you don't get to kill people for being born with magic or a love for the same sex."

Yeah, She-Ra wouldn't budge on that. Although drawing the line at killing people wasn't a bad idea. "Well, if you stick to that, you shouldn't have too many problems," Jack said.

"And we'll have to leave the cultural stuff alone in exchange?" Catra cocked her head sideways. Like a cat.

"Uh…" Daniel took a deep breath. "It's a really touchy subject. A lot of countries want to foster a sense of… patriotism. Loyalty to the nation. Taken too far, that can be seen as an attack on minorities and their cultures. It's controversial," he added with a shrug.

"Well, we don't want to meddle with the internal affairs of others if we can help it," Glimmer said. She didn't look happy, though. "We don't want to replace a government or occupy a country."

Jack was glad - the Etherians occupying another country would be a disaster for everyone involved. It would probably make the

worst CIA attempts at regime change look competent.

And it would probably be worse for the Etherians than Vietnam had been for the USA. Jack really didn't want to see them broken like some of the vets he knew.

"So, we're going to talk to the United Nations," Glimmer said. "Voice our concern. Mention how genocide violates their own charter. And hope they get the message."

Jack couldn't help himself. "And if they don't?"

"Then we get to train planetary invasions and decapitation missions," Catra said with a wide grin.

"It's not funny, Catra!" Adora protested.

"I know."

"Oh, you!"

Jack really hoped that the United Nations would get their act together. The Etherians getting bogged down in an insurgency would be a nightmare - and the best thing to happen to the Goa'uld.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, October 2nd, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and as you can see here, in this example, restoring a planet's magic doesn't change its biosphere significantly or instantly. It merely activates the magic field you can tap into if you have the talent. You can check the data yourself; we've included it in the folder you've got."

Entrapta was great at this, Adora thought as she watched her friend explain magic to various diplomats - again. Glimmer would have lost her temper long ago. Had lost her temper, actually,

when she had heard of the request to explain once more what magic did and didn't. Fortunately, she hadn't been in public. Her choice of words would have caused a lot of friction with Earth.

Entrapta, though, saw nothing wrong with explaining things over and over again. Probably because she was used to talking to bots who were slow learners at the start when their control matrices had just begun to develop. Which was why Entrapta was here, explaining things, with Adora helping out, since Bow was with Glimmer, and Catra and Hordak wouldn't be of any help here - quite the opposite.

"If one has to learn to, ah, tap into that field, does that mean there won't be any magical plants or animals? I mean, how would you teach them that?" a diplomat asked.

"Good question!" Entrapta beamed at him. "There are actually plants and animals back on Etheria which use magic. But they either evolved to make use of magic or are the result of genetic engineering by the First Ones. Now, it's not impossible that Earth had such plants and animals as well - you had magic until a thousand years ago, and the Ancients and other species certainly had enough time to experiment on Earth - but those organisms would have been affected by the loss of magic." Entrapta pouted a little. "I guess some might have gone extinct. If they needed magic to fly or breathe water, for example. Or survive in hostile environments. On the other hand, if they just used magic for non-essential powers, they could have survived. And a thousand years is a short time for evolution to lose such a power, so they might regain it."

"So we will have to worry about dragons and other monsters returning?" another diplomat gasped.

Entrapta looked confused. "Why would you worry about that? Creatures that went extinct wouldn't magically appear. And while some organisms might regain the use of magic - on an instinctive level - Earth had magic until a thousand years ago, and you obviously could handle whatever magical creatures were around

just fine back then - and now you have far more advanced technology!”

“How could you know that?” a delegate from one of the hostile countries asked with a glare. One who, unlike others, hadn’t left. Instead, he had stayed and spent his time trying to make magic look evil.

“You’ve got records going further back,” Entrapta explained. “If magical creatures were such a threat, they’d show up in your documents.”

“There are countless myths and legends about dangerous monsters!”

The British delegate shook her head. “With all due respect, but those myths and legends talk about single incidents. Local problems, not something that affected entire countries, much less the world. Please stop your fearmongering. If dragons reappeared tomorrow, we probably would have to treat them as an endangered species right away.”

A number of people laughed at that. But Adora could see that more were still concerned.

“There is another aspect,” the delegate from Japan spoke up. “We have myths of foxes and tanuki who could take on the form of people. Obviously, they would have to be intelligent for that. And obviously, neither species currently possesses such intelligence. If the myths are based on truth, though, and such animals can, with the help of magic, become sapient, how could we continue to keep them from that?”

“Animals taking the form of people?” the hostile delegate spat. “What if they breed with humans? We cannot allow that to happen! Earth is no place for half-animal abominations!”

Adora was really grateful that Catra wasn’t present. Her lover would have ripped into the bigot. Maybe even literally.

"It figures you'd think of sex right away!" someone else snapped through the muttering this comment caused.

Entrapta, as usual, was unfazed. "If they can have fertile offspring with humans without technological or magical intervention, they would be the same species, so they would be humans," she said, smiling. Then she cocked her head to the side and put her finger on her cheek, frowning a little. "Of course, if an inherent magical ability would allow them that, one would have to consider whether or not that classification is still true." Then she shrugged. "Not that it matters as long as both are intelligent, right?"

It was obvious that not everyone shared her view.

"May I remind some of our esteemed colleagues that we're here to have questions about magic answered, not to debate whether or not magic should be restored," the British delegate said.

That helped to quiet things down a little. Only a little, though. And while Entrapta didn't mind explaining things, Adora was getting a little fed up with it.

So she had to control her expression while Entrapta told the delegates that, yes, in theory, plants could develop deadly magical poison. But the plants would have had that a thousand years ago, so people would know. And magic wouldn't suddenly make plants and animals and people change into something else. Well, not without a spell or a device.

Which didn't go over well. That genetic engineering could do much more, as Entrapta pointed out in response to the exclamations, didn't really help either.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 3rd, 1998

"...so it took a few repetitions, but they finally understood how magic works." Entrapta beamed as her hair fiddled with a few of

Samantha Carter's tools in her lab.

"You must be saint!" Dr Georgovich - who insisted Sam and Entrapta should call him Iwan - exclaimed. "Explaining to politicians?" He shook his head. "Easier to explain mistake to commissar!"

"Commissar?" Entrapta cocked her head to the side while her hair didn't move.

"Oh, communist commissar. Very bad, very strict, no humour. Used to motivate and punish everyone in old Russia."

Entrapta didn't look like she understood Dr Gregorovich's black humour, so Sam cut in: "The political commissars were functionaries responsible for the morale of the soviet military. They have a reputation for brutal punishments without often bothering whether or not their victims were actually guilty."

"Yes! USSR collectivised everything, including punishment!" Dr Gerogovich chuckled. "One for all, and all for one, da?"

Entrapta wrinkled her forehead. "That sounds… not very nice."

"It was brutal and unjust," Sam said.

"Da! Make mistake? Be called saboteur! Other make mistake? Be called saboteur! Off to Gulag either way - if you lucky!"

"A gulag was a forced labour camp in the USSR," Sam explained.

"Oh."

"But I think we have exhausted that topic," Sam went on, narrowing her eyes at her colleague.

"Ah, yes. Sorry. Not everyone like Russian humour." Dr Gregorovich nodded. "We were talking about you teaching politicians!"

“Yes!” Entrapta perked up. “It’s like teaching bots - just tell them until they understand.”

That reminded Sam of the old joke about trying to explain a joke to a sergeant-major, but she pushed the thought away. She didn’t want to get side-tracked again. “Did you explain magitech as well?”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded, then frowned. “I thought that would make them understand how silly their fears are about sorcerers when technology using magic will be much easier to build and use - by anyone, not just sorcerers. But they didn’t seem to understand that.”

Sam suppressed a sigh. “People generally don’t feel better about something which they’re afraid of if you tell them there are worse things to fear.”

“Ah.” Entrapta nodded again. “I see.”

Sam wondered if she did but didn’t ask. That would’ve been rude.

“Ah! I understand why orders came to focus on magitech research!” Dr Georgovich nodded enthusiastically. “I told superior that I am scientist, not wizard, but did he listen? No!”

So the Russians were looking into magic combined with technology. Like the United States. Or that was what they wanted you to think - she heard the Colonel’s voice in her mind.

Not that it mattered - the subject was fascinating. The possibilities were almost endless. And you didn’t need to be a sorceress or princess to work with it - or to build it. But a sorceress in your team should make researching new such technology much easier. Or would - the only trained sorceress amongst the Etherians on Earth was Glimmer, and not only was she very busy with diplomacy, but she also didn’t seem fond of doing research in a laboratory. Well, maybe if they recruited Bow? That might entice his girlfriend to work with them, and… Sam pressed her lips

together. That was a very manipulative plan. She knew better than that. She was better than that.

She'd crack her most recent project soon enough with just Entrapa as a lab partner. Or science buddy, as Entrapta called it.

But, she added to herself as she saw Dr Georgovich smiling at Entrapta, she would have to consider if she wanted to risk Russia getting access to her project. In theory, she was working for Stargate Command, under the control of the United Nations. In practice, Sam had no doubt that every scientist at the gate had some projects that they weren't supposed to share. Or at least data.

"SO!" Entrpata beamed at her. "Want to research bots that can track magic?"

Sam blinked. That would… Well, it would certainly be very useful. Very powerful. But also very dangerous for anyone with magical talent. And it wouldn't be very hard to construct - she had some ideas about the magic scanner they had built. If it could use magic to detect Naqadah, it was likely that magic was detectable as well. And…

She sighed. She really hated to do this to Entrapta, but even if it wouldn't prevent someone from inventing this in the future, the last thing they needed was a magic detector on Earth right now. "I would love to, but there is a problem with that…"

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, October 3rd, 1998

"...and tensions remain high between India and Pakistan despite the Secretary-General of the United Nations personally meeting with both country's prime ministers. Protests in support of Pakistan have erupted in several Arab countries, and the police had to stop a mob attacking India's embassy in Riad with lethal force…"

"...and then we'll cover how this new development will affect the numerous Indian migrant workers in the Gulf States…"

"...PETA stated that with the possibility of animals gaining sapience thanks to magic, eating meat now definitely was murder, and called for the immediate abolishment of…"

"...latest polls show even greater support for the proposed amendment to the constitution regarding gay marriage and other rights, although a number of holdout states and members of congress continue to…"

"...rumours about the Etherians planning to address the United Nations about the state of human rights in the world persist, though nothing has been confirmed yet, and…"

"...Amnesty International voiced their concerns about the state of human rights in Etheria, citing the lack of formalised protections and international oversight, and the absence of democratic structures and a free press in the countries ruled by monarchies as worrying, and…"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Why do they have so many channels if it's all the same?"

"It's not the same," Hordak said, moving the bowl with snacks a little closer to him. "You can spot the biases of every news organisation by comparing them to each other."

Catra snorted. "And since when are you an expert on news agencies? The Horde didn't have any news!" Only propaganda.

"But the Horde had scouting and reconnaissance troops, whose reports I read regularly." He sounded a little smug. "I learned what was lost between the lines of any report depending on who made it."

She snorted again."I know how bad the casualty rates were in that branch. How long did a regular scout last?"

Hordak huffed and stuffed some fried corn into his mouth. Probably to avoid answering her. “Long enough.”

Catra grinned. “You mean, you knew a few soldiers and how they worked.”

“Just like there are a few channels worth watching,” he shot back.

“Whatever,” Catra said, grabbing a drink. “We can’t…”

“There you are!”

Catra turned her head. Adora had burst into the lounge. “Yes?” she said, her ears twitching. Adora knew she had been taking a break in the lounge.

“We have a problem!”

“What?”

“Did something happen to Entrapta?” Hordak said, getting up.

Catra tensed. If anything had happened, it would have been on Earth. And Entrapta was the only one of them currently on the planet, having taken the shuttle down to Stargate Command. Everyone else was on Darla.

Adora blinked. “Uh, not that I’d know.” She shook her head. “But we have a problem - we have fan mail!”

“Fan mail?” Catra cocked her head.

“Yes, fan mail! People who like us are writing to us to tell us that they like us!” Adora nodded emphatically.

“And why is that a problem?” Catra asked. That sounded like, well, not a bad thing.

“Because we haven’t been answering them!”

Oh.

*****

“How did that happen?” Glimmer sounded angry - and looked angry - but Catra couldn’t help suspecting that her anger wasn’t so much because of the fan mail problem but because her time with Bow had been interrupted. Her clothes did look a little rumpled.

“Well…” Adora looked a little guilty, too, for interrupting them, Catra thought. “Apparently, since we didn’t have an official mail address, the mail was shuffled back and forth between various countries without getting delivered. Some letters were returned to the sender.”

“And they didn’t tell us?” Glimmer growled.

“Well, they did, today - kind of. Mostly by accident, when a clerk in the United Nations wanted to know if we now had an official mail address. It seems that they had to screen the mail for poison and bombs and such, and then tried to find an official mailing address, and kind of sent the mail back forth between the countries before storing it all in America and going through the diplomatic channels to ask us about it. But we found out that the request never reached us.” Adora frowned. “I don’t know how that could happen. They could have just sent it to Stargate Command and let them contact us.”

“Back home, I’d blame Kyle,” Catra said with a chuckle.

“Or it was sabotage,” Hordak added.

Catra doubted that. It sounded more like some screwup. Unless, of course, there were important messages that had gotten lost as well. She narrowed her eyes. “So, they scanned our mail for bombs and poison? And maybe sensitive information?”

“We should have gotten an official mail address,” Bow said. “We should get one, in fact.”

"Yes!" Adora agreed. "And we need to answer our mail! And apologise for not doing so sooner!"

"Great," Catra grumbled. As if they didn't have better and more important things to do. But Adora cared about that. And Catra cared about her. "Let's go and collect the mail, then."

There went her relaxing evening in the lounge.

*****

US Postal Service Storage Facility, New York, Earth, October 3rd, 1998

"...and I am terribly sorry about this. We didn't know you weren't informed, so we just kept storing the mail. We didn't want to bother you, you know - and we couldn't. We're storage, not customer service. We asked the management to contact you; that was all we could do." The flunky in the ugly uniform was wringing his hands, Catra noted. Not that she cared. Not faced with…

"We need to get Darla down here," Adora said. "That won't fit into the shuttle."

"I'm not sure it'll fit into Darla's hold," Bow said.

"Not without stuffing every nook and cranny with letters, including the lab," Glimmer said.

…a small mountain of letters. Catra shook her head. How could the people on Earth have missed so many letters? Usually, they loved their paperwork!

"I'm really sorry, but regulations being regulations…"

Catra glared at the man, and he shut up.

"Well…" Adora grimaced. "I think this will take us a little longer to process than I expected."

“We could just set it on fire,” Catra suggested.

Glimmer looked like she’d agree, but Adora gasped. “Catra!”

“So, that’s a no?”

“Catra!”

*****

Dear She-Ra! Are you really a Princess? Art, that’s my brother, said princesses are stupid and not real, but I saw you on TV! You are so pretty and tall and strong! How can I become a princess? Love, Maggie

Catra snorted, folded the letter and put it back into the envelope, then waved it at Adora. “Here’s another one for you!”

Adora sighed as she took it and put it on the huge stack next to it. “Thanks.”

“No problem.” Adora’s stack was the biggest so far, Catra saw. Well, that was to be expected - Adora was the greatest, after all. The humans had good taste.

Catra grinned as she picked up the next letter.

Dear Bow! I just wanted to let you know that I think you’re the best! A techmaster and archer, you’re like a black Green Arrow! Do you have the same trick arrows as he has? If you don’t know Green Arrow, he’s a superhero, only he doesn’t have any special powers, except for his trick arrows, and he’s a master archer! I’m taking archery lessons already! Is Bow your superhero name, and do you have a secret identity? Yours sincerely, Tim.

“Bow, you’ve got a fan!” Catra grinned and threw the letter over to Bow.

“Thanks!” He smiled, though he looked a little… disturbed.

“What’s wrong?” Glimmer had noticed it as well.

“Just…” He sighed, then held up a letter. “They’re thanking me for being a good black role model. And they said their son’s father was in prison, and they’ve been trying to find good role models for their kid… They’re asking if I could visit the kid’s school.”

Ah. Catra suppressed a snort.

“Well, we should have time to visit a school…” Adora said.

“And then turn every other request down?” Glimmer shook her head. “We can’t visit everyone who asks.”

Adora frowned. “But they’re so earnest… This girl asks me to come show her class that girls loving girls is OK.”

“Where is it from?” Bow asked.

“Canada.”

“I think they already know that there,” Glimmer said,

“Well, it seems no one told their school yet,” Adora said. “Although the letter’s a month old.” She put it down on another pile after pinning the envelope to it.

“I think their government already told everyone that girls loving girls is perfectly fine,” Catra said. At least she remembered a letter thanking them for showing that gay marriage was a human right from there. “Canada’s on the list for an alliance meeting, right?”

“Yes,” Glimmer said. “They haven’t pushed, though.”

“They’re probably too polite for that,” Catra joked.

“Oh! This one’s for you, Glimmer!”

“Thanks.” Glimmer tried to act as if she didn’t care, but Catra had caught her glancing at the much larger stack of letters for Adora a few times. Glimmer opened the letter and blinked. “They’re

thanking me for doing so much to return magic. And… they invite me to visit their coven? And share my knowledge of magic, but only if I want to?"

"What's a coven?" Adora asked.

"A group of witches working together, part of Earth's magical traditions," Glimmer said.

"We don't have time to visit every coven," Catra reminded her. "Besides, magic hasn't been restored yet. You'd just have tea with them."

"They want the visit after magic has been restored," Glimmer said. But she was pouting.

Well, that was her problem. It wasn't as if Catra cared about the fact that the number of letters addressed to her was smaller than Glimmer's. She wasn't a princess, after all.

And, she spat with a slight hiss after reading the next letter, "I don't hunt mice!"

Glimmer chuckled.

"Really," Catra complained. "Why are so many people interested in my fur and ears and tails?"

"Most of us look like humans. You're different," Bow said.

"And you're much prettier than Hordak," Adora added with a smile.

Well, of course, she was! Catra straightened a little. "That's why they want pictures." Lots of picture requests, actually. Almost as many as Adora's, if the stacks were any indication.

"Signed pictures are commonly traded on Earth, I believe," Bow said.

“And we can print them en bloc and send them out without losing too much time,” Glimmer said.

“We could also create action figures!” Bow said, smiling. “Or figurines.”

“Yeah, because we want people playing games with us.” Catra snorted.

“Well, that wouldn’t be bad, would it?” Bow asked.

“Who cares.” Catra shrugged. “We’re here to protect Earth and find allies, not to sell pictures or figurines.”

“We wouldn’t sell the pictures,” Adora said.

“We actually should,” Glimmer corrected her. “Or we’ll be swamped in requests. More than we already are,” she added with a glance at the mountain that had barely shrunk in the hours since they started. Still too much for the shuttle. And too much for Darla’s hold. Maybe they could commandeer a frigate’s hold for this…

“Oh.” Adora gasped.

“What?” Catra narrowed her eyes.

“This boy said his parents were in heaven and, since we have spaceships, asked if I could bring them back…” Adora sighed and put the letter down.

Catra suppressed a curse. Damn, she had thought the letters from people calling them names and wishing them dead were bad, but this… “Let’s take a break!”

“But we still have so many letters to go through…”

“Yes. And they’re not going to disappear,” Catra told her.

Unfortunately.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 4th, 1998

"Fan mail?" Jack O'Neill resisted the urge to mime cleaning his ears. Carter wouldn't appreciate it - she had glared at his latest joke, even though that had been a good one. Probably encountered some problem she couldn't solve easily. Although he couldn't spot anything like it in the lab. Maybe it was some theoretical physics stuff.

"Yes, Sir," Carter said, nodding. "The Etherians apparently received vast amounts of fan mail and are now undecided about the best way to cope with it."

"What's the problem? Write a form letter, print it a few hundred times, send it to everyone. Or hire people to send the letters if that's beneath a princess," Jack said.

"The amount of mail they received was much larger than a few hundred letters," Carter replied. "Apparently, due to a bureaucratic mishap and unclear regulations for international mail delivery as well as some politics at the United Nations, all the mail addressed at them - at least from North America and Europe - was collected since their arrival."

Jack whistled. That would have to be a lot of letters! And a bureaucratic mistake? He would bet that this was part of an attempt to gather intel. Or control what the Etherians heard from Earth. Just what the NID would do. Still… Even a mountain of letters just meant the Etherians would need to hire more people and print more form letters. So why wouldn't they? "Is there some Etherian cultural thingie that means they have to reply personally to every letter?"

Daniel was frowning at him, but Jack couldn't tell whether that was for his wording or not knowing if there was such a taboo.

"I doubt that," Carter replied. "Entrapta told me that she wanted to construct a reply-bot."

Jack nodded. That fit the princess. "Could you ask her if she could construct a paperwork-bot?" he joked. Well, semi-joked. Some help writing reports would be nice.

Carter was rolling her eyes, so her mood must have improved. "I will not abuse my friendship with her to save you from doing your work, Sir."

Jack carefully didn't point out that relaying to your superiors what your alien buddy told you while you were tinkering in your lab was a sort of friendship abuse by itself. He would do the same in her place - the Etherians were crucial for the world's defence, after all, and anything that upset them could have catastrophic consequences.

Besides, people had been doing this kind of gossipping since ancient times. Probably since the time of the Ancients.

"Uh…" Daniel pushed his glasses up. "Entrapta might not have the same cultural views on answering mail as her friends - they do come from different kingdoms on Etheria, and Etherian culture, even though it might appear so from an outsider's point of view, is very diverse. In fact, I would bet that, without the global media networks, Etheria's culture is more diverse than Earth's, at least relative to their population."

That was a lot of words for 'other Etherians might have that rule'.

"That's possible." Carter nodded, but Jack could tell she wanted to contradict Daniel.

"Anyway," Jack spoke up, "our alien friends having to cope with letters from their adoring fans doesn't look like a huge problem." Or any problem at all.

Carter shook her head. "There were also letters from people who didn't like them. Some were rather… crude."

Ah. “I hope they aren’t planning to answer those in person.” That could be a problem - Jack didn’t want to imagine what Catra might do to someone threatening her. Or Adora. Or propositioning them.

“Not to my knowledge, Sir,” Carter replied.

“Good.”

“The Etherians, despite the medieval aesthetics of some of their cultures, do not share the kind of warrior culture that requires insults to be repaid with violence,” Daniel said.

Jack looked at Teal’c. The Jaffa, on the other hand… It was probably a good thing Teal’c wasn’t receiving such mail.

“Indeed,” Teal’c spoke up as if he had read Jack’s thoughts. “Although while Jaffa society differs in that area, it would be dishonourable for a trained warrior to actually fight an untrained civilian over such insults. However, a thrashing, as you would call it, would be perfectly appropriate.”

Of course, pretty much every adult Jaffa was trained in combat, Jack knew. He nodded anyway. “So… what do you think they’ll do? Should we give them advice on how to treat cramps in your hand?” He grinned - Adora would easily heal that, anyway.

Carter straightened. “Ultimately, it’s their decision, Sir.”

“But we can give them advice on what’s an appropriate response in our society,” Daniel said.

“And we don’t want them spending all their time writing letters by hand to explain to little Timmy that they won’t blow up his school to save him from his homework,” Jack joked.

“No, we don’t,” Carter said. “I already told Entrapta that there’s no expectation of a personal reply in such cases.”

“Looking out for your science buddy?” Jack smiled. Carter probably also didn’t want Entrpata to waste time on answering letters instead of doing science with her.

“Sharing data.” Her smile was a little toothy. He probably shouldn’t joke about being jealous of letters. “But, apparently, they have received a number of requests for personal visits.”

“And are they planning to do that?” Jack asked. They’d need good security - with all the furore about magic, there was bound to be a nutcase who would try to blow up the ‘evil aliens’. He blinked. ‘Furore’? He must have been listening to Daniel a bit too much lately.

“I don’t know, Sir. It’s apparently something they still have to discuss.”

“Like the return of magic?” Jack asked.

“Entrapta seems to be under the impression that they are merely waiting for the right moment to do that, Sir.”

Great. Jack clenched his teeth. He wasn’t looking forward to dealing with Dungeons and Dragons in real life. And if some idiot decided that Jack might have a magical talent because of his Ancient ancestry and wanted to send him to magic school…

He really wouldn’t like that.

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The Magic Question Part 3

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, October 7th, 1998 (Earth Time)

They were facing the full assembly of the United Nations. So many countries were represented here. If Adora hadn't faced them before, and if she hadn't attended Princess Prom, she would feel nervous. Well, more nervous. This was, after all, an important meeting. For everyone. Fortunately, Adora didn't have to take the lead here.

"...and we welcome Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, who will address the Assembly."

Adora watched as Glimmer, wearing her coronation outfit - or something like it - rose and walked up to the microphone.

"Thank you!" She smiled and put her up notes - Bow had installed a small projector on her pad so she could read her speech without glancing down all the time. "I'm happy to be here and talk about an important issue - two important issues, although they are related. First, I want to announce that the Princess Alliance will support the United Nations and enforce international law in the case of genocide. We, the people of Etheria, were the target of such crimes, and while we managed to defeat the criminal aiming to murder us all and destroy our planet, many other planets suffered this fate before us. We would dishonour the memory of those people if we would look away should someone else attempt a genocide. As we came to Earth to stop the Goa'uld from invading your planet and murdering your civilisation, we will protect you against such crimes committed by others on your planet. Just as your own laws stipulate, we will do what we can to stop any such crime." Glimmer nodded.

Adora didn't miss that not everyone in the audience seemed very enthusiastic. Actually, a lot of the ambassadors who applauded seemed to be doing so with polite smiles rather than honest or

enthusiastic support. And a lot of the audience looked angry and were talking to their neighbours.

"Told you so," Catra whispered. "They care more about their sovereignty than their own laws. Or the lives of others."

Adora didn't frown - that would have been misunderstood, what with cameras covering everyone - but she whispered back: "Just because they are concerned about us trying to impose our will on them doesn't mean they would rather face a genocide."

"Someone listened once too often to Glimmer practising the speech." Catra had the last word before Glimmer started talking again.

"This does not mean that we will invade a country or impose our own laws or customs on anyone. All we will do, should a country or organisation attempt a genocide, is to stop them and capture the criminals." Glimmer nodded. "We are not planning to start a war, change a country's government or political system. We will absolutely not occupy a country. But if anyone is starting a genocide, we will stop them."

"And what is your definition of genocide?" one ambassador yelled. Adora checked the flag - it was Saudi Arabia.

They had prepared for that. "Acts with the intent to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnical, racial or religious group," Glimmer replied. "That's in your own Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide, which your country ratified decades ago."

"And what about the permanent members of the Security Council?" another ambassador - from Algeria - asked before she could continue.

Adora pressed her lips together. They had expected that question as well, but she had hoped they could address it after the speech.

Glimmer, though, raised her chin slightly. “I do not think any of those countries will attempt to support genocide in that manner. However, the Princess Alliance is of the opinion that, should a genocide be attempted, saving lives takes precedence over adhering to formalities.”

That caused an uproar, and Adora clenched her teeth. Did they really expect the Alliance to let any country stop them from saving people?

“This is an attempt to take over the world!” someone yelled just as the noise started to die down - Adora didn’t catch who said it.

“No,” Glimmer replied, her amplified voice filling the assembly. “This is not an attempt to take over the world. This is just a warning - if you attempt genocide, we will stop you. Just as your own laws stipulate and expect of you. We will not let you murder people for the crime of being born, no matter who you are or who you are allied with.”

The assembly erupted in shouting and yelling again.

“Looks like genocide is more popular than we thought,” Catra commented with a sneer.

This time, Adora frowned at her.

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It took a bit of time for the assembly to calm down - the Secretary-General had to step in and remind a few of the ambassadors that they were in public and had to behave with a certain decorum, though it wasn’t as bad as the Princess Prom had been. No one attacked anyone, in any case. And there had been Alliance meetings that had been as loud and contested, though those were private.

But finally, Glimmer could continue her speech. “In addition to clarifying our stance towards genocide, we are also here to inform you about our decision with regards to Earth’s magic.”

“Here it comes!” Catra whispered - she sounded as if she were looking forward to this. She probably was, Adora realised.

“After considerable deliberation and consulting various trusted people, we have decided that we will honour the request to restore magic to Earth. We have…”

Glimmer’s voice was drowned by shouting and yelling, even louder than before - it almost hurt Adora’s ears, and she saw Catra clench her teeth and flatten her ears. Adora knew how sensitive her lover’s ears were; this had to hurt her.

She reached out and patted Catra’s thigh. As she tried to make out what the people were yelling.

“This is an outrage!”

“How dare you force magic on us!”

“Blasphemy!

“Finally!”

“We will not let you corrupt our people!”

“This wasn’t your decision!”

“You have no right to do this!”

“No, *you* have no right to keep us from regaining our heritage!”

“This is an act of war!”

“You are changing our entire life on a whim!”

“Take your magic and leave!”

It took a few more minutes until people had calmed down - no, until people stopped screaming. Adora had no doubt that they hadn’t really calmed down. Not the people who were glaring at her friends and herself.

Glimmer, who had weathered the storm without showing her annoyance, except for narrowing her eyes, continued: "As I explained, we decided to honour the request to return magic to your planet. We are aware that this is a controversial issue, but we do not think that anyone has the right to dictate to another that they cannot use magic; it's your heritage. It's part of your natural environment. Your planet had magic until a thousand years ago, and it will regain what was stolen from it."

"You're forcing this on us!"

"No one forces you to use magic," Glimmer went on without glancing at the ambassador of Kuwait, who had blurted that out. "But we will not let those who hate and fear magic for petty and bigoted reasons dictate how everyone else on the planet should live."

Adora nodded. Just as they wouldn't let the bigots oppress people like her and Catra.

"You can't just dismiss our concerns!" the ambassador of Saudi Arabia yelled. "This is against our religion. You are trying to change our way of life by force!"

"And we don't care!" Catra hissed through clenched teeth - fortunately, not into a microphone.

"Your concerns are unfounded," Glimmer replied. "You fear magic, yet you embrace technology. And you desire advanced technology that will change your life much more than magic - and is far more dangerous. And can be used by anyone."

"This is the core of the issue," said the ambassador of… Adora had to squint to read the sign. Of Nigeria. "Anyone can use technology. Only a few, as you explained, can use magic. We do not want to be ruled by witches and wizards."

Catra rolled her eyes.

“And you won’t,” Glimmer told them. “As we explained multiple times, it takes both talent and years of study to gain any significant skill at magic - and even with both, you won’t be able to subjugate a country, much less the world.”

“You are ruling your country,” the ambassador retorted.

“Yes,” Glimmer replied. “And several countries on Earth are ruled by monarchs as well.” She looked at the ambassador of Saudi Arabia. “But I didn’t conquer Bright Moon with magic.”

Adora glanced at Catra, but her lover refrained from commenting that Angella had conquered it. Or might have - the records were a little vague.

“And in our war against the Horde, several kingdoms ruled by princesses fell to an enemy who didn’t use magic, but technology.” Glimmer shook her head. “The return of magic will not lead to monarchies being restored or imposed on you.”

“But a few might get toppled,” Catra whispered, baring her teeth.

Adora glared at her. That wasn’t helping!

“This will cause a panic,” the ambassador of Sudan said. “People will accuse each other of being evil witches! People will die!”

“People are already dying,” Glimmer said. “You don’t need magic to have witch hunts.”

“But it’ll be worse, now that people know it’s real!”

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded, her expression fixed. “It will get worse. But it’ll also get better once you realise what magic can and can’t do. If we don’t restore magic, not only would we be helping those amongst you who wish to keep what was stolen from you out of ignorance and selfishness, but we would still see witch hunts.” She narrowed her eyes. “And all the bigots would have realised that they can force their views on others if they threaten to hurt and kill enough people. And that would mean things would grow far,

far worse." She shook her head. "If the threat of people being murdered would be enough to make us keep magic from being restored to Earth, we might as well surrender to the Goa'uld because they wouldn't hesitate to murder their slaves if they thought that would make us back down." She scoffed. "It won't."

Adora firmly nodded. As much as she hated how this decision would lead to people getting hurt and killed, the alternative would be worse. You could not give in to people who would hurt others to make you obey them. You wouldn't save anyone that way.

"You could delay this, though! Let us adapt slowly to it!" the ambassador of South Africa said.

"We have been delaying this." Glimmer shook her head. "We've explained what magic is, how it works, what you can expect. If people still think magic is evil after our explanations, then delaying further won't help either."

"Yeah," Catra muttered. "Let's get this over with so we can focus on the war instead of on idiots."

Adora frowned at her, but Catra had a point. This had already taken too long. Far too long. People were suffering under the rule of the Goa'uld. It was time to settle this.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 8th, 1998

"So, they said I shouldn't build a reply-bot because we don't know enough about Earth customs regarding correspondence. And I said that if we don't know enough to build a reply-bot, we don't know enough to reply ourselves."

Samantha Carter nodded and tried to suppress the sudden and petty burst of annoyance she felt upon hearing that. She had been looking forward to working on probe bots, not explaining how you wrote form letters without offending the recipient. It

wasn't a subject she was very experienced with, anyway. Well, if you counted the 'Dear John' letter she had to write at the academy, before her first deployment, but…

Entrapta shrugged. "So, they're going to talk to Julie and Mr Brown about that and then tell me if I can build a bot." She beamed. "I hope I can - I've never built a reply-bot. It would be an entirely new bot type. Very delicate manipulators, so it can write using Earth pens. And a new control matrix since it would need a completely different set of parameters to handle is task compared to a usual bot. I mean, I built lots of different bots, from combat bots to servant bots, but I haven't really focused on language expression - so far, their sound emitters using a set of signals was good enough, as long as they understood me." She blinked. "In hindsight, that was a little unfair, wasn't it? They could understand my language but not speak it. None of them complained, ever - well, not even when they went all murderous after getting infected with a First One virus - but maybe others would have been nicer to them if they could talk?"

Sam nodded. "People do treat you differently if you can speak their language." Whether it also went for bots… she didn't know. Would a bot be seen like C-3PO or Data? A sapient being? Or like Ed-209? Emily talking, perhaps with a British accent, would likely be off-putting. Then again, humans had a tendency for anthropomorphism. People attributed human traits and emotions to their pets and computers - not that Sam would ever do that! - and so doing that to bots would only be logical.

"Then we should work on that!" Entrapta nodded. "It'll make all bots better, too - probe bots will be able to report what they saw and answer questions!"

"That would also introduce bias with regards to their data, though," Sam pointed out. "Since they would have to interpret the data to report it. Unless they just repeat the numbers." But that would be a waste of a language module.

“Right. Even with self-learning matrices, we couldn’t be sure about the results of their interpretation. But wouldn’t it still be helpful? As a second opinion? As long as we treat the data without being biased, which any scientist should, anyway. Right?”

Sam nodded. It was time to do science.

*****

“I think we should take a break,” Samantha Carter said a few hours later, resisting the urge to run her hands through her hair before she got them cleaned - Etherian bots used lubricants as well, after all, though how exactly they had arrived at prototyping new manipulators from mapping out language matrices was a little unclear in hindsight.

“Aw…” Entrapta pouted, her hair still holding a small scouting bot’s parts in the air. Then she blinked. “Although now that you mention it, Hordak said I should eat more regularly when working.”

“Where is Hordak, anyway?” Sam asked before she could help herself. While the former warlord didn’t come along with Entrapta every time she came to the mountain, Sam hadn’t seen him for some time.

“He’s checking with Priest about planetary drop tactics,” Entrapta replied while rooting through the fridge in Sam’s lab. “Do you have some of those tiny snickers I saw on TV?”

“No, sorry. You’re the first person I met who prefers the small bars to the full-size bars,” Sam replied. “I’ll order some for your next visit.”

“Thank you!”

Sam made a note, then frowned. “Planetary drops?”

“Yes. In case the fleet needs to intervene on Earth. They’re worried about that, you know?”

Sam had known about the announcement to the United Nations regarding genocide - she was sure almost everyone on Earth had heard about it, the way the news had spread. Some pundits were claiming this was the first step to invading Earth. “Do you expect to intervene?”

Entrapta shrugged. “It seems illogical, but if everyone acted logically, people wouldn’t fear magic. Catra thinks someone - some country - will be stupid enough to attempt genocide out of spite. Bow thinks they won’t since genocide is illegal on Earth. Glimmer agreed with Catra, but she was mad when she did that. Adora said she hopes that we won’t have to intervene.”

That was a very detailed report. “Well, many people are afraid of magic,” Sam carefully said. “And they tend to lash out against what they fear. It’s irrational but common.”

“It’s stupid,” Entrapta said, nibbling on a Snickers. “We’ve explained how magic works several times. Even a restricted bot would have understood by now.”

That was pretty harsh for Entrapta. She didn’t seem very concerned about the potential deaths that the Etherians’ decision might cause, though. “Do you think you will be able to stop any genocides?” Sam asked.

“I guess so? Once we hear about it, in any case. We’re moving more ships into orbit so we have more ground troops. Mostly bots, but they should work for this kind of mission.” Entrapta shrugged again.

“Many people could be killed before anyone notices,” Sam commented. That had been the case with Rwanda a few years ago.

“Yeah, but we’re keeping an eye on the countries that were the worst about it so far.”

She couldn’t help it - she had to ask. “You don’t seem to be worried.”

"Worried?" Entratpa tilted her head to the side in an almost comical fashion.

"About the deaths," Sam explained. "You won't be able to stop all killings since you need to detect them first before you can intervene."

"Oh!" Entrapta nodded. "Yes, but that can't be helped. I thought about improving our scanner so we can spot lives ending, but that is tricky - lots of humans die every minute - and Catra told me that it would be depressing if we just watched people die without being able to help. I think she meant Adora would find it depressing - Catra's usually not really bothered about that."

"Seeing people die is not something everyone can handle," Sam pointed out.

"I know." Entrapta nodded. "We can just do our best and go on."

That sounded like something someone told Entrapta, and she took it to heart. "Who said that?" Sam asked.

"Perfuma. She's very good about that stuff. I wish we had taken her with us," Entrapta said.

Sam didn't know the other princess well enough - or at all - to agree. But things could have gotten better with the Etherians, that was certain.

On the other hand, Sam was only too aware of how much worse things could have gone. If Perfuma thought the Etherians should intervene more on Earth, to do their best… "Let's get back to work," she said.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, October 8th, 1998

"...and the riots in India have spread to most northern states. The military, already mobilising to protect the border, has been

ordered to reinforce security forces. The number of deaths hasn't been determined yet as reports are still coming in from more remote parts of the country where protests and counter-protests clash violently, often fueled by ethnic and religious tension as well, and…"

"...the group of anti-magic protesters holding a vigil in front of the Reichstag has required police protection from counter-protestors accusing them of being bigots, and…"

"...in response to the riots that killed dozens of migrant workers from India in the Gulf States, the Indian Prime Minister accused the UAE of deliberately neglecting their duty to protect the residents in their countries and called for 'all sons and daughters of India to return home', threatening that any attempts to prevent them from leaving the UAE would be seen as a hostile act against India, and…"

"...Egypt, where the situation had barely calmed down since the riots following the catastrophic explosion, the military has moved against the protestors with brutal force as reports of people getting lynched as 'witches' and 'blasphemers' mount, and…"

"...Israel Defense Forces have been put on full alert again, and reservists have been called up as the country prepares for an upswing in violence following the fighting between factions in the Westbank, and…"

"...French troops have secured the airport to organise an evacuation as law and order in the capital of Mali are breaking down, and mobs started witch hunts…"

"...in Kabul released a statement declaring their intent to fight 'blasphemers and witches to the death', although, so far, it remains unclear who exactly the Taliban consider as such and how they plan to fight them. Experts commented that…"

"... of the European Union denounced the anti-magic violence and called for swift and decisive action to prevent further loss of life…"

"...the Arab League denounced both the Princess Alliance as well as India and Japan for causing this 'avoidable tragedy with their blatant attempt to oppress Islam and force magic on our people' and once again called on the United Nations to pass a resolution banning magic from Earth, which…"

"...Japanese government released a statement that Japan did not feel responsible for the violent actions of people trying to prevent Japan from recovering its cultural and religious heritage, and offered India their full diplomatic support in…"

"...the president has released a statement that all US citizens in countries affected by the sudden surge of anti-magic violence should evacuate…"

"...the stock exchanges are reeling as several major oil exporters in the Middle East announced an oil embargo against 'any country supporting the imperialist actions of the Etherians'. The United States is expected to release the strategic reserve any day, and several members of the Senate have been calling to secure the oil supply even though the United States has not been put on an embargo so far, and…"

"...protests in several European cities have been demanding the release of advanced technology to compensate the effects of the oil embargo even as Russia announced stepping up production…"

"...a group of Wiccan celebrating the imminent return of magic were attacked in Los Angeles, leaving two seriously wounded. The LAPD originally judged it to be a gang-related shooting but was forced to widen the investigation to cover a possible hate crime, and is expected…"

"...der Bundeskanzler wiederholte, dass Deutschlands strategische Ölreserven freigegeben werden würden und dass die Regierung alle nötigen Massnahmen treffen werde, um die Versorgung des Landes zu gewährleisten. Genauere Angaben zu den Massnahmen machte er nicht, aber…"

"...Indonesian government has declared a state of emergency and ordered a curfew in response to growing unrest…"

"...Swedish authorities stated that the apparent suicide of a family of five in Stockholm was being investigated and that reports of the family being very religious and concerned about magic 'corrupting their souls' could not be confirmed at the moment…"

"...have announced to fight the 'blasphemous forces of the devil to the last bullet and barricaded themselves in their church when police officers arrived on the premises. So far, it's unclear what prompted the police intervention, but locals are already voicing their concern that this might lead to another Waco-style massacre if not handled carefully and…"

"...the Pope has released a statement calling on all Catholics to remain calm and assuring them that the return of magic was no threat to their immortal souls provided they wouldn't…"

"...leader of the protesters in front of the White House stated that they wouldn't go home until the government banned magic in the United States, claiming that the United States was a Christian country and…"

"...the Met intervened and broke up a so-called 'exorcism'. A child of eight years was moved to a hospital for treatment, and…"

Catra flicked the screen off and shook her head. "They've gone crazy." At least the rioting and worse was limited to countries in the Middle East and Africa, for the most part.

"This is awful!" Adora blurted out. "We have to do something!"

"And what can we do?" Glimmer asked. She pointed at the bridge's window, where Earth was floating beneath them. "Start conquering Earth?"

"No, but…" Adora shook her head. "This is our fault."

Catra hissed. "It's not our fault!"

“If we hadn’t announced our decision to return magic, this wouldn’t have happened.”

Well, she wasn’t wrong, Not technically. But…

“Should we have bowed to pressure and kept magic from those who wanted it back?” Glimmer asked with a frown.

“No, but…” Adora pressed her lips together. “We shouldn’t have done it like that.”

“We knew that there would be violence,” Glimmer retorted. “Like when we revealed ourselves.”

“But we didn’t think it would be that bad,” Adora shot back. “It wasn’t that bad back then.”

“It’s not your fault,” Catra said. “Nor our fault. As Glimmer said - if we bow to violence, we might as well surrender to the Goa’uld.”

“But those aren’t the Goa’uld down there! They aren’t brainwashed soldiers or slaves fooled by evil fake gods!” Adora protested.

“Doesn’t look like much of a difference to me,” Catra scoffed. “Attacking people over magic sounds pretty evil to me.”

Glimmer nodded but she looked grim. “Yes. We can’t bow to the threat of violence. Not from anyone.”

Bow, thought, shook his head. “We should have handled this better. We could have… avoided this.”

Catra snorted, even though she didn’t feel amused. “Really? Sat down with the witch hunters and politely explained that they’re wrong? Showed them the light? Explained how magic works?”

“Yes!” Adora blurted out as Bow nodded.

"We did that at the United Nations, and we couldn't even convince their ambassadors," Glimmer pointed out. "Why do you think this would have worked better with the people in their countries?"

"And how long would that have taken?" Catra added. She sneered. "Should we have told India and Japan, and everyone else who isn't an idiot, that they can't get magic back because it might offend the same people who were offended by our relationship and provoke them into rioting?"

Adora bit her lower lip. "Well, no, but…"

"We could have made more of an effort to convince people that magic isn't going to ruin their lives," Bow said.

Glimmer glared at him, which was a bit of a surprise. "Yes, we could have done it. And it would have been a waste of time. They don't listen! We keep telling them how magic works, and they do not listen!"

"Some are concerned about magic causing more problems," Bow retorted.

"Yes. And those people aren't down here rioting and murdering others!" Glimmer yelled as she jumped to her feet. "The fanatics are! The people who hate everyone who isn't like them and want to kill them!" She bared her teeth. "I am sick and tired of trying to talk to them, trying to reach them, trying to make nice with them when they DO. NOT. WANT. TO. LISTEN!"

She screamed the last words and stalked out of the door.

Catra looked at Adora, who looked shocked, and then at Bow, who looked like Scorpia had hit him with a tank. "I think Glimmer needs a break from diplomacy," she said.

Adora slowly nodded.

Bow shook his head. "She needs…" He trailed off.

"Go talk to her," Catra told him. After a moment, she nodded at Adora. "Both of you." For all her words, Glimmer wasn't taking this well.

Bow was already moving, but Adora looked at him, then at Catra.

"Go! She needs you," Catra told her. "I'll keep watch here."

And, she added to herself as Adora left the bridge, I'll try to ignore the insanity down there.

It's not our fault, she repeated to herself.

Yet she still felt guilty.

*****

Dulles International Airport, Washington DC, October 10th, 1998

Jack O'Neill watched the truck - the second truck - leave the hangar. He half-expected a few letters to fall off it, to be blown across the tarmac by the soft breeze he could feel, but whoever had done the loading had done a good job with the Etherians' fan mail. "I pity whoever has to deal with all that mail," he commented as he started walking towards the hangar.

"That would be Brown, Wallander and Co. and Julie Callaghan, I believe," Carter said. "Entrapta mentioned that they decided to let 'experts in communication' handle it."

"Dumped the whole thing on PR weenies?" Jack chuckled. Not exactly a surprise - he couldn't see any of the Etherians spending all their time answering mail. Although he wasn't sure if it was a good decision, with all the violence about magic shaking the world, the mail was bound to reflect that, and Jack wouldn't trust PR firms to handle that. In more sense than one. "Have they been told about the threat of mail bombs?"

“Entrapta said she built a bomb-detecting-function into her reply-bot.”

Jack blinked. “She built a paperwork bot? And I wasn’t told as soon you heard about it?” He narrowed his eyes at Carter.

She tilted her head slightly as if she didn’t know what he was talking about. “It was in my report about robotics, sir. And it wasn’t a paperwork-bot. Merely a bot physically able to write letters. It still needs to learn how to write and, more importantly, what to write. Its neural network is in its infancy and won’t be able to handle even basic letters for a while.”

“You make it sound like a baby,” Jack told her.

Carter blinked. “That’s actually an apt description, sir. The bots are learning like children, though often from a set of base skills.”

“So…” Jack grinned. “You basically made a baby with Entrapta?”

Daniel gasped, but Carter merely narrowed her eyes. “We constructed a bot, sir. And it cannot help you do your paperwork.”

“Pity.” Jack would have added another joke, but they reached the hangar’s entrance - where that combat bot of Entrapta’s, Emily, was standing.

“Hi, Emily!” Carter greeted it, and the oversized R2-D2 with a tank cannon beeped back. “Yes, we’re fine. No, it’s safe. There are no violent protests in the city.”

Jack privately wondered if Carter wasn’t spending a bit too much time with Entrapta. “I didn’t know you spoke robot.”

“I am familiar with the general signals of Entrapta’s bots since I worked on communication modules with her, sir.”

“Ah.”

“Sam!” And there was the magical mad scientist, coming straight at them - walking on hair and waving. “Did you get my message about the random phrases generator?”

“Yes. Although I am not sure if that is a good teaching tool. It seems…”

Jack tried to tune out the tech talk and focused on the shuttle waiting inside the hangar.

“It doesn’t look like it could carry so many letters,” Daniel said.

“They made multiple trips,” Jack explained. The brass hadn’t wanted to see a Horde frigate land in Washington. Apparently, the optics would have been bad - as if having a few dozens of the things in orbit was any better. The retired generals making the talk-show circuits were already commenting on how vulnerable the United States were now and how much they needed an alliance with the Etherians to replace those shiny white ships with grey hulls of their own. Which led to this meeting, not that Jack thought anything would come of it. Not until Washington finally managed to legalise gay marriage and all that stuff.

“Ah.”

And there was the rest of the Etherians, walking down the ramp - together with a man and a woman. Mr Brown and Miss Callaghan - Jack had seen their files. They didn’t look happy. Jack wouldn’t be happy in their place, either, having to deal with this.

“...and we’ll get back to you once we have a better overview of the trends,” Callaghan was saying. “We should have vetted more people by then as well.”

“Hi, Jack.” Adora looked… not as perfect as she usually did. Tired.

Most of the group looked tired, actually, Jack noticed as they exchanged greetings, and SG-1 was introduced to the PR weenies. “So, you’re going to handle the mail?” he asked. “Like working for Santa at Sears?”

“We’re handling it as part of public relations.” Mr Brown sounded slightly prissy. No comment about Jack’s joke even though he should be old enough to understand it. Definitely prissy.

So Jack waited until the two had left in a limousine and a sports car, respectively, before addressing the Etherians. “So… How are you doing?”

“Not going to say ‘I told you so’?” Catra narrowed her eyes at him. Prickly, there. More than usual.

Jack shrugged. “I guess you’ve been beating yourself up enough already.” They certainly looked the part.

“The loss of life is a tragedy,” Glimmer said. She looked pissed, actually. “But the blame is to be placed at the feet of those who use ignorance and fanaticism to try and impose their narrow views on others through violence.”

“Did you run that by your public relations consultants?” Jack asked before he could help himself.

Glimmer’s glare intensified. “No. That’s not their expertise.”

So, did that mean they would listen to experts?

“Well, if you need experts on the Middle East and Africa, I know several people in the field,” Daniel offered with his ‘I only want to help you’ smile.

Glimmer scoffed. “You want to tell me that you have experts that know how to make religious fanatics accept magic?”

Daniel blinked. “Well… not exactly. But they know the cultures of those regions and how to interact with people there without offending them.”

Catra snorted. “We know that as well - we would just have to ban magic and stop loving each other. And probably convert to whatever religion those people follow. Or die for our sins.”

Jack couldn't help chuckling, which made Daniel pout at him. "It's not quite that bad," his friend insisted.

"Really?" Glimmer openly sneered at Daniel. "Do you think if we just used the right words, they'd be fine with magic?"

"No, no, but… a more diplomatic approach might have avoided some of the riots." Daniel smiled rather weakly. "Maybe."

Glimmer bared her teeth - for a moment, she reminded Jack of a furless angry Catra. "We tried that. We talked to their ambassadors for hours and hours! The only thing that would have prevented this would have been to agree not to return magic."

Daniel winced. "Well, yes, but… wouldn't it have been worth to delay restoring magic to Earth to avoid all this loss of life?"

"Delay for how long?" Glimmer asked, stepping up to glare at him from up close - or down close since she was smaller than Daniel. "Until those fanatics suddenly accept magic?"

"We'd be dead before that happens," Catra added. "From old age. And what about the United States?" She looked at Jack. "Would your country agree to, I dunno, stop eating meat if enough vegetarians threaten to riot? Wouldn't it be worth to ban meat if it prevents such a loss of life?"

Jack could almost physically feel the sarcasm aimed at Daniel.

"It's not the same," his friend argued. "Magic affects everyone:"

"So does meat production," Adora said. "Many countries grow feed for animals instead of food, and export it." Jack blinked, and she shrugged. "I was curious about Earth farming after you visited a farm in Bright Moon."

Ah. Jack nodded. He should have expected that.

"It's still not the same," Daniel argued.

“The principle is the same. How many deaths does it take to make your country stop doing something?” Glimmer asked.

“I think the United States of America don’t negotiate with terrorists,” Catra added. “At least not officially.”

“We are talking about countries, not terrorists,” Daniel retorted.

“Same thing,” Catra shot back. “They threaten violence against other people to make us do what they want us to do.”

“And speaking of terrorists,” Jack said, raising his voice a little. “We’re here to talk about coordinating responses with the fleet and security concerns, not politics, right?”

Everyone looked at him as if they were surprised at his words.

Jack frowned. He could be diplomatic if he needed to. He just usually didn’t want to. “Anyway, the new ships in orbit are a concern for some people,” he said. “Like the Pentagon.”

“A concern?” Adora asked.

“Yes.” Jack nodded.

“Oh.”

“And that has nothing to do with our announcement that we won’t let people commit genocide?” Catra asked, raising her eyebrows.

“Well, I don’t think the people who asked me to talk to you are bothered by that,” Jack replied. “America doesn’t do genocide.”

“Not any more,” Daniel just had to add.

Fortunately, the Etherians just nodded. They were really forgiving with all the second chances they gave everyone. “Yes, we’re aware of your country’s past,” Bow said. “But as you said, you’ve changed.”

“Yeah. Anyway, I was told to pass along that having spaceships with big honking space guns flying in the sky could make people nervous and afraid, and that can trigger bad responses to surprises - or rumours.” Jack wasn’t going to mention ‘bad optics’, or anything like that. That would make the United States look bad.

“Ah.” Adora nodded. “We don’t want people to panic.”

Jack almost bit his tongue to avoid pointing out that they had done a very good job at making people panic. “Sometimes, things happen that you didn’t intend.”

Catra snorted but didn’t comment.

“We’ve got Mr Brown and Julie working on explaining things better,” Bow said. “So people won’t write us to ask things we can’t do - we don’t want them to get their hopes up.”

Jack blinked. “You really got letters asking you to blow up a school?”

“Some ask us to go to heaven and bring back their parents,” Glimmer said with a scowl.

Jack winced. He had stepped into that one. “Yeah. That’s a toughie.” He suppressed the sudden urge to ask if they actually could do that. If they could, they would certainly have mentioned it by now - people would do anything to get their loved ones back. Hell, Jack would do anything to get Charlie back. No! He shook his head. Dead was dead. People didn’t come back from death.

Glimmer nodded. “So, we’ll ask them to also explain that we’re not going to invade Earth.” She sighed. “They’ll ask us to give another interview.”

“Well…” Jack shrugged. “It makes you look approachable if you appear on TV.”

“We really don’t have the time to give lots of interviews,” Glimmer retorted. “We’ve got diplomatic meetings every day.”

Judging by the way the others reacted, those meetings sounded as bad as Jack thought. He didn't envy them.

"Well, your public relations people did a good job," Daniel said. "The majority of Americans support an alliance with Etheria."

And the massive and often questionable efforts of the government and the NID, of course, Jack thought. It was easier to change public opinion if your most vocal opponents happened to have all their dirty laundry exposed at the most inconvenient moment.

"Before or after we announced that we'd stop genocides no matter what country did it - or tried to use their veto in support of it?" Catra asked with a scoff.

"Actually, that stance received a lot of support from those who feel that the veto power in the United Nations Security Council should be abolished - which includes a lot of people in smaller countries," Daniel said. "Although I've only seen statistics for countries with a free press."

"You can bet that every Chinese and Russian is shocked by the implications of your new policy," Jack added with a chuckle. "Just ask their propaganda ministers."

"Russia isn't the USSR, Jack!" Daniel complained.

"Close enough," Jack shot back. They certainly weren't a free country yet. Not with so many former communists and even KGB members now in positions of power.

"Anyway, we can't cover every country - and if we only grant interviews to American journalists, we'll be accused of being biased," Glimmer said.

"It's hard enough just meeting with the diplomats and governments," Adora added. "And we need to prepare for every meeting by reading up on the country's history."

“Ah, paperwork!” Jack nodded sagely. “I feel with you. And speaking of feelings…”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “We’ll tell Priest to keep the ships out of low orbit.”

That was probably the best Jack would get. Well, it was no skin off his butt, anyway. His ego wasn’t so fragile that seeing ships in orbit would threaten it. Certainly not when he was already aware that far more ships were in the system. “Thank you,” he said. “So… with that out of the way, and your public relations guys already gone, is there anything else official-like we need to talk about?”

“Yes.” Adora sighed. “We could use some help with security for public appearances. India has invited us to restore magic on their soil next week.”

“Oh.” Jack blinked. He hadn’t heard about that. No one had, as far as he knew.

And he had a bad feeling about this.

*****

Indira Gandhi International Airport, National Capital Region, India, October 17th, 1998

Adora couldn’t help looking around reflexively as she stepped on the ramp of the shuttle. Entrapta’s scanner hadn’t detected anything like a trap or an ambush, but she couldn’t help worrying. There were so many people cheering and yelling, kept at bay by soldiers. So many opportunities to hide an attacker. Even after a week, Jack’s lecture on sabotage and assassination was at the forefront of her mind.

Even Jack’s team - with the exception of Teal’c, who had added some advice of his own, based on his experiences as First Prime - had seemed to have been taken aback a little by his obvious personal experience with all that stuff.

“Relax. The tarmac is clear,” Catra said as she joined her on the ramp, walking slowly down behind Glimmer and Bow. “No bombs in range.”

Her lover had been taking notes and nodding a lot during the lecture, Adora remembered. And she wasn’t sure if Catra had just been concerned about defending against such attacks. Or limiting such attacks to Goa’uld.

But it had helped with the security for today’s visit. Thanks to the scanner, the Indian police had already arrested three groups of people planning to attack the ceremony with bombs. And a few more had been ‘dealt with’ according to the Indian government when searched for weapons by the police before being allowed on the field reserved for the ceremony. Jack would be happy about the security here - the Indians had tightly locked up the entire area.

But this wasn’t the time to talk about that. She nodded, forced herself to smile and kept walking toward the delegation from the Indian government. Unlike visits to other countries, the Prime Minister himself was waiting there, a big smile on his face.

“Keep an eye on his bodyguards,” Catra whispered into her communicator.

Right. One Indian Prime Minister had been assassinated by her own bodyguards.

“Emily’s on the job!” Entrapta replied over the channel. The two were following Adora and Catra - and Adora noticed a number of the soldiers standing guard looked a little nervous when they saw Emily. “Her force field is ready to be deployed. But she does miss her cannon.”

“Poor baby,” Catra muttered - sarcastically.

Adora was tempted to elbow her, but they had just reached the Indian delegation.

“Welcome to India! We are honoured and proud that you have chosen our country for this historic moment!” The man looked jovial and honestly happy. Well, he had campaigned hard for this - of all the countries, India had been the most vocal about restoring magic.

“Thank you,” Glimmer replied. “We’re honoured to be here.”

“Yes,” Adora added with a nod. “We’re happy to finally return what was stolen from you.” By her ancestors and in an attempt to build a super-weapon that would have devastated an entire sector. But this wasn’t the time to discuss this particular subject, either. Still, it felt good to right this wrong. She might not be responsible for the actions of the First Ones, but she still felt guilty.

They exchanged handshakes and greetings with the rest of the delegation - Emily, encouraged by Entrapta, waved one of her legs, balancing on the others, which prompted some laughs from the audience and even from the Prime Minister himself.

And from some of the soldiers. Well, the ones standing guard. The ones standing at attention in the ‘honour formation’ didn’t laugh or move at all while Adora and her friends walked past them. Adora still didn’t know why practically every country on Earth had soldiers do that for state visits, but it made adapting to such visits easier.

“...and you picked a good time to visit; the monsoon has ended, and the weather is quite nice.”

It was actually still quite hot and humid, but Adora nodded. And even Catra didn’t complain about the effects on her fur. Her smile looked a bit more toothy, though, as they climbed into the waiting cars that would take them to the field chosen for the ceremony.

Not that an actual ceremony was necessary. Adora could have restored the magic to Earth anywhere on Earth. All it took was using She-Ra’s power to remove the last remains of the First Ones ‘magic shunt’, as Entrapta called it. The enchantment that had

siphoned off the planet's magic and still kept it from returning to Earth. They didn't know exactly where the magic was going, actually - part of it at least was used to keep the shunt in place, but the rest seemed to be vanishing into another dimension, according to Entrapta's latest theory.

It didn't matter. Soon, this would stop, and Earth's magic would be restored.

Adora smiled, both at the thought and at the people lining the street, cheering at them. After all the bloodshed on the news, it felt so good to be welcomed. To see people wanting their stolen heritage returned.

"I wonder where they put their protesters," Catra whispered while she waved herself.

Right. Not all Indians were happy with magic returning. But most were. India's Minister of External Affairs had assured them that they wouldn't be bothered by 'fanatics trying to disturb the ceremony', but he hadn't gone into details. Just that they were banned from entering the area of the visit.

"Ah, looks like they missed some," Catra said.

Adora tensed as she saw the scuffle in the distance - lots of soldiers were there, beating some people and dragging them away. Lots of other people were joining in, trying to beat them up. She winced at the sight, but they were quickly driven past the spot.

"At least the cars are armoured," Catra said.

Adora nodded. Anyone taking a shot at them would have to use a heavier weapon to threaten them - and those would show up on the scanner Hordak was currently watching from Darla. And they would have force fields at the ceremony.

Still, Adora felt a little on edge. So many people - most of the world - would be watching her. What if she botched it? If she tried

to restore magic, and it didn't work… No. She had done this before. She knew how to do it. Everything would be fine.

Everything… that was a lot of people. Adora blinked.

Catra whistled. "Somehow, it looked smaller from orbit."

Adora nodded. It was like looking at a sea of people. "There must be millions of them."

"Yes."

"Well, it would look smaller from a longer distance and from a different viewing angle," Entrapta said. "But I know what you mean."

"Indeed," the Prime Minister cut in. "Every true Indian wishes to be present when our divine heritage will be returned to us."

"Except for those who think magic is evil," Catra commented.

The man frowned for a moment. "Yes. But rest assured that none of them will be present to mar this occasion. We've purged them from the guards assigned to this ceremony as well."

Oh. "Purged?" Adora asked. She had read about such purges…

"Reassigned to duties that take them away from the region," the Prime Minister explained with a slightly forced smile. "We're not barbarians."

Ah. That was reassuring. Somewhat, at least. But not overly much. As far as Adora knew, most of the people in India who didn't want magic returned were members of a religious minority. To persecute every one of them for the views of some of them…

But they had arrived now, the car slowing down as it passed a checkpoint, then drove through a narrow lane kept open by double-rows of soldiers holding back a cheering crowd. Flowers were thrown at them, and Adora flinched for a moment before

she reminded herself that they were in an armoured car and would have detected any explosives in the crowd.

And there was the huge stage, where the delegations from other countries, members of the Indian government and other honourables were waiting.

More greetings followed. Many more. Adora shook hands with the Japanese Prime Minister, with familiar faces from the United Kingdom - they had sent the Crown Prince - and France, Germany and the United States, and many other people she hadn't met yet. By the time they were finally done with the greetings, the sun was high in the sky, and Catra was cursing under her breath about the heat.

And now the Indian Prime Minister was starting his speech. He was a poet of sorts, Adora had read, and well-liked - the people were cheering at almost every word - but…

"I'm growing hungry," Catra complained in a whisper.

"There's going to be food afterwards," Adora whispered back.

"I know. I can smell it in the tents behind us," Catra replied.

"And I can hear you," Gimmer hissed. "Shh!"

Adora blushed a little. She should have known better than to respond to Catra in a situation like this. She couldn't be rude to their hosts - everyone, the entire world, was looking at them!

She took a deep breath. Besides, it wouldn't be much longer - how long could the Prime Minister talk, anyway? Any minute now, he would finish, and…

Hordak's voice coming through their communicators interrupted them. "The scanners show a disturbance in a military base to the east."

"Disturbance?" Catra sat straighter, tensing up.

“Fighting. Between soldiers - they’re wearing the same uniform.”

“Traitors or infiltrators,” Catra spat. “What’s their goal?”

“The artillery park, it seems.”

Adora gasped. Artillery? What was the range of the guns? Emily’s force field would stop an artillery shell, even a barrage, but she couldn’t cover the entire area, and if a shell struck the tightly-packed crowd…

One of the soldiers on stage was listening to his radio as well, she noticed. And looking pale.

“Who’s winning?” Glimmer asked, leaning over. No need any more to care about how it looked - more soldiers were moving now, as well as bodyguards.

“It looks like the attackers are winning,” Hordak said.

Adora blinked. How long would it take them to aim a cannon at the field here? A few minutes, probably, if they had ammunition and a trained gun crew. That had been Horde standard.

“They’re attacking the magazines as well,” Hordak reported.

That was… Adora clenched her teeth.

“Are we in range of their guns?” Glimmer asked.

“According to our data, yes,” Entrapta said, staring at her tool. “Emily can stop the shells from hitting us, but she can’t protect everyone here.”

Like Adora had thought. This was…

“Hordak, stop them!” Glimmer snapped.

“Fire!”

A moment later, Adora saw a beam strike the ground in the distance, followed by explosions. And then an entire volley of beams struck. And more explosions followed, dust forming columns of smoke that billowed up.

Orbital support, she realised - they had trained for that. But secondary explosions? In the Indian Army base?

“The attackers are dead,” Hordak reported. “There was some collateral damage as the magazines were neutralised.”

Adora wasn’t listening any more. She was staring at the crowd in front of her. The people were panicking. Screaming. Pushing against each other and the soldiers as they tried to run away from the explosions. She saw a soldier being overrun, people trampling over him, heard more screams, saw a little girl stumble and fall, and a man step on her…

She gasped. The crowd, the sea of people, was going crazy. And soldiers were moving in front of the stage, brandishing weapons. Trying to protect the Prime Minister and his guests with lethal force.

“No!” she yelled, standing up. Raising her arm. Summoning her sword.

“For the Honour of Grayskull!”

A familiar rush filled her. Her armour formed. She was She-Ra, Princess of Power!

The people around her - those who didn’t know her - stopped and stared. But that wasn’t enough. The crowd was still panicking. People were being hurt. People were dying.

She stabbed her sword upwards and focused. On her power. On her magic. Reaching out to that familiar pattern. Connecting.

For a moment, everything turned white as the magic of the planet ran through her. She almost screamed. There was so much, it was

so hard, so…

And flicked her sword. Cutting the pattern. It was like popping a balloon. One moment, she felt like she was about to burst from the power filling her. The next, the pressure was gone.

Mostly. She was still glowing brightly with power. With magic. Blazing.

She turned, looking at the crowd. The hurt and the dying. The panicking and the crying.

Adora raised her sword, then brought it down.

And a wave of magic burst from her blade, sweeping over the crowd. A wave large enough to cover the entire area as she turned.

Healing.

Soothing.

Earth’s magic. Used for the first time in a thousand years.

*****

The Magic Question Part 4

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 17th, 1998

"We're tracking six frigates in orbit above the Indian subcontinent. They're holding positions."

"No further weapon fire detected."

"Six more frigates are in a holding pattern over the northern hemisphere."

"Five minutes until our next satellite is in position to cover the area of impact."

Samantha Carter blinked at the reports from the other officers in the command centre even as she continued to analyse the data from all the sensors networked with her mainframe. They should have satellites in place already… Oh. She pressed her lips together. The United States had satellites in place already. But Stargate Command didn't control them - or had access to them. Not any more. They had to make do with the satellites transferred to Stargate Command.

"What do you have for us, Carter?" The Colonel was leaning over her desk.

"I'm still cross-checking the sensor data, sir," she replied. "But so far, it looks like a limited bombardment. Precision strikes with standard laser weapons from low orbit."

"Precision strikes?" He raised his eyebrows, then looked at the TV screen in the back, where a mushroom-shaped cloud was visible in the distance.

"Those are secondary detonations," she told him - as if he didn't know it already. "The Etherians must have hit the magazines of the base." She hit a few keys, checking the most recent satellite

image - which was still not up to date. But the intel report… "Artillery and tank shells were stored at the base," she said.

"And the terrorists would've gone for them so they could use the captured artillery pieces." The Colonel nodded. "And so our magical space princesses blew the base up."

"The magazine was surrounded by revetments," she informed him. "Its explosion should not have destroyed the entire base." They would know more as soon as the satellite finally reached its intended position.

Sam really missed the Air Force Stargate Command and its resources. Having to rely on CNN for real-time intel was a shame. She bit her lower lip. She might not know the access codes for the US satellites any more. But she knew how to get them - which cache memory to access and how. This was a global emergency, wasn't it? Maybe… She blinked, then sighed. She had better alternatives.

"One moment, sir!" she told the Colonel and pulled her phone out.

He didn't make a joke about texting or ordering pizza. Which was kind of reassuring - the Colonel joked and quipped the most when the situation was desperate.

"What are you doing?" And here came Sidorov.

Sam suppressed a sigh as she turned to face the General. "Getting more information, General." She called Entrapta.

"Sam! How are you doing?"

Her friend didn't sound as if she was in danger. Or concerned. But that was Entrapta. "How are you doing?" Sam asked. "We received reports of an orbital bombardment."

"Oh. Yes, Hordak had to destroy the guns and ammunition before they were turned against us. Emily could've protected us, but not everyone else. But we're fine now! And the panic has stopped!"

“Who are you talking to?” Sidorov snarled.

“Princess Entrapta,” Sam told him - as if it wasn’t obvious. “The situation seems to be under control.”

“Under whose control? The aliens’?”

“Well, they have all those ships in orbit,” the Colonel cut in.

Sidorov glared at him, then turned back to Sam. “Are they landing troops?”

“Who is that yelling in the background? We aren’t invading, by the way. Hordak is just a bit protective.”

A little? Compared to Priest, maybe, Sam thought. “So you are safe?”

“Yes, everyone here is safe. I think. The soldiers here didn’t start fighting each other.”

“How reassuring,” the Colonel said with a snort.

Sam didn’t smile. India was in a special situation, with significant parts of their Muslim minority opposing magic, not helped by a nationalist Hindu party controlling the government, but the United States had their share of religious fanatics with similar views. Probably in the armed forces as well.

“Yes! Anyway, I’m not sure if the ceremony will continue, but there’s no fighting here.”

Sam smiled wryly. “Yes, I doubt the festivities will just go on as planned.”

“Does this mean that magic won’t be restored?” General Petit had arrived with the rest of the generals in tow.

Entrapta must have heard him. *“Oh, no, Adora already did that. She used the excess magic to heal the wounded here.”*

"That was the light show on CNN," the Colonel said.

"What? They already did it?" Sidorov bellowed.

Sam narrowed her eyes. "My report clearly stated that, according to the Etherians, restoring a planet's magic doesn't take She-Ra longer than a few minutes." Did anyone actually read her reports through?

"Or faster if there's artillery fire incoming," the Colonel added.

A beeping noise alerted Sam to the incoming satellite footage. She put it on the big screen. And winced.

The base wasn't entirely destroyed. But the magazine and the parked guns were gone. Presumably with everyone in the vicinity. There were survivors amongst the soldiers, as far as she could tell. And some would just have been wounded.

But she didn't think there would be too many of those. Not where the lasers had struck. Or near the explosions.

"The Indians won't be happy about that," the Colonel said.

Sam nodded in agreement.

*****

National Capital Region, India, October 17th, 1998

The orbital bombardment had stopped, but smoke was still rising on the horizon. At least the target was destroyed, so there shouldn't be any more… Ah, no, there was another secondary explosion. Even Catra's ringing ears - why did crowds have to be so loud? - caught the sound.

She bared her teeth as another smoke cloud rose, this one tinted with red and orange. Probably a fuel depot - Entrapta had explained that this was how fuel explosions looked when they had

watched one of Earth's action movies and wondered about the blasts.

"I think their damage control isn't any better than their security," she commented. First, a mutiny, now this… She looked at the crowd around the stage. Most of them looked stunned. Blinking and patting themselves down. One man in a bloody shirt was holding his nose as if he couldn't believe it was still there.

Well, that was Adora's healing magic for you. Catra knew the feeling better than anyone else.

Next to her, Adora sighed, closing her eyes and staggering a little.

Catra grabbed her arm and steadied her.

"Thanks," Adora whispered, taking a deep, shivering breath before standing tall again.

"Anytime," Catra whispered back. She wouldn't let her lover down.

She looked around. The Indian soldiers had used the shock from Adora's magic to form a square around the stage, three lines deep. Others were surrounding the Prime Minister - and arguing. The man didn't want to leave the stage. He wasn't the only one - the British Crown Prince was also still on the stage, although Catra could barely spot him behind the two massive men standing in front of him. Not nearly as tall as Scorpia, of course, but She-Ra wouldn't tower much over them.

But other dignitaries had been dragged off by their security detail; Catra saw cars still rushing off.

"I do not detect any more hostilities," Hordak reported through their comm channel. *"The fleet is on standby."*

Good. Catra wasn't sure if the danger was over. She straightened, facing the nearest guards. They couldn't look weak. Not surrounded by such a crowd, and right after they had turned a

local army base into a crater. Sure, the base had been about to be overrun, and if the mutineers had used the artillery there, they would have caused a massacre, but people didn't like you blowing up their bases no matter your reason.

"So much for their security," Glimmer muttered.

"Why did they have artillery here, anyway? We're not even near their border with Pakistan," Bow asked.

"They must have been fearing an invasion from orbit," Glimmer told him.

"But we're guarding the system." Bow blinked. "And those guns wouldn't do anything against our ships."

"They probably weren't aware of that." Glimmer shrugged. She still looked angry.

"But we told them about our capability when we discussed the security for this, didn't we?" Entrapta asked.

"We did," Catra said, baring her teeth. "But they probably didn't really believe us. Or they just felt better with their biggest guns around."

Glimmer chuckled, and Entrapta looked confused, but before Catra could explain her comment, the Prime Minister walked towards them, pushing a particularly stubborn security guard out of the way.

"What did you do?" he asked.

"We stopped a terrorist attack," Catra replied. She managed not to sneer.

"You destroyed a base of ours!" another man snapped. He was listening to a radio. Right - Catra remembered that he had been introduced as India's defence minister or whatever his exact title was.

“The base was taken over, and they tried to use the artillery there,” Glimmer told him. “Did you want us to let them shell us here?” She pointed at the crowd.

“Emily can’t cover everyone here with her shield,” Entrapta added. She still was too open with military information, in Catra’s opinion. “We would have been fine, probably, but if they missed us, the shells would have struck the crowd.”

“And that would have been a massacre,” Adora said.

“You killed our soldiers!” the minister protested.

“They were mutineers,” Catra retorted. “And about to take the guns.”

“We had it under control!”

“Yeah, right - we saw it from orbit. Your soldiers had already lost.” Catra sneered.

“We weren’t about to wait until they shot at us here - at everyone here - before stopping them,” Glimmer said. “We’re sorry about the dead loyal soldiers, but we had no choice.”

“You could have…”

The Prime Minister interrupted the man. “I didn’t mean that.” He looked at Adora. “What did you do here? With your magic?”

Oh.

She glanced at Adora. Her lover straightened, towering over everyone but the two British bodyguards. “I restored magic to Earth. And then I healed everyone,” she said with a slow nod.

“Everyone?” the Prime Minister asked.

And Adora winced, suddenly looking embarrassed. “Well… everyone present in the area. I couldn’t exactly limit the healing

magic to just the wounded, and there was a lot of magic available, so I just healed everyone here."

"Everyone?" the Minister of Defence asked.

It has to be stupidity, Catra thought - if he were hard of hearing, Adora would have cured it.

And, of course, her lover was too nice to just call the man out for it and explained again: "Everyone I could see here, well, figuratively - even if they were in the middle of the crowd, I could heal them. It's more a figure of speech."

"We haven't much data for targeting healing spells," Entrapta cut in. "Usually, it's either aimed at a single person or a clearly defined area effect. She-Ra's magic is kinda an exception."

"Sorry if you would rather have stayed wounded or sick," Catra added with a toothy smile. "But saving lives was more important."

"But the healing was safe?" the Prime Minister asked.

"Yes." Adora nodded firmly. "I controlled the magic. So there won't be any side effects - I just healed you."

"That won't bring back our dead!" the Minister of Defence spat, still holding his radio. "The base was wiped out! Hundreds of our soldiers are dead!"

"Does that include the mutineers?" Catra asked.

"Catra!" Adora hissed.

"Just asking," Catra said, shrugging. "It must be hard to sort out the mutineers from the loyal soldiers if all were wearing the same uniform."

"We know how many soldiers were stationed at the base."

"Ah."

Glimmer took a step forward. “We’re sorry about your losses, but we couldn’t let the mutineers take control of your artillery.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “I can heal your wounded soldiers, but I cannot raise the dead.”

“Thank you,” the Prime Minister said. “It was a very difficult situation, but…”

Loud yelling from the crowd behind them interrupted him. He turned, frowning. “What are they…?”

“I can see! I can see!”

“It’s a miracle!”

“I can see again!”

Catra narrowed her eyes at a man walking towards the line of soldiers, the crowd parting before him. He was surrounded by crying people and holding a white staff above his head.

The Prime Minister blinked. “You gave him back his eyesight?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Adora healed every one of everything,” she said.

“Of illnesses and wounds, cancerous tumours and accumulated microdamage over the course of your life,” Entrapta said.

More people were screaming and yelling. Catra saw one man stand on shaking legs but raising a wheelchair over his head while he cried.

The Prime Minister seemed to freeze for a moment, then quickly bent his knees, straightening up. “I feel no pain,” he said. “It’s as if I were young again. Is… Is this permanent?”

Entrapta spoke before anyone else could say anything. “Well, as permanent as healing - you’re not hurt or hurting any more, but

you can still get hurt again. You're just very healthy right now. You're not immortal if you wondered about that."

He laughed. Then he blinked again. "And you did this to everyone here?"

Adora nodded.

He smiled widely, then bowed. "Thank you very much."

The Minister of Defence was staring at them, his mouth half-open, as all around them, the diplomats and dignitaries started to talk to each other. They sounded excited.

"Well, that's one crisis averted," Bow said behind Catra.

She turned and glared at him. "Bow!"

"What?" He looked confused.

"Don't jinx it!"

"But…"

"We've started a bigger crisis," Glimmer mumbled. "Look at the crowd!"

Catra did. The people - even some of the soldiers - were staring at the stage. At She-Ra. Smiling. Crying. And…

"What are they doing?" Adora asked.

Catra snorted.

Praying. They were praying to She-Ra.

"They're worshipping you," she told her lover.

"Oh no!" Adora shook her head.

"That might actually be a good thing," Catra said. "Priest is less likely to attack a country full of people worshipping you."

Adora glared at her, but Glimmer and Bow nodded.

Entrapta was busy scanning the crowd.

And Catra looked at the mass of journalists and their cameras. Earth would know, or knew already, what She-Ra's magic could do.

She cursed under her breath.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 17th, 1998

"...and many are calling this a true miracle, although the Etherians' press release stated that this was merely 'high-level healing magic powered by a unique build-up of magic'. Are those merely semantics, or is this a meaningful difference? We have invited experts on…"

"...of Pakistan denied any ties or responsibility to the mutineers who attempted to attack the Restoration Ceremony in India, yet…"

"...police and military forces have been deployed to prevent violence as many Hindus are blaming all Muslims for the attack despite the Prime Minister himself speaking out against this and calling for all Indians to remain peaceful and celebrate the return of magic 'despite the brutal and bloody terrorist attack', as he called today's incident…"

"...reports of hundreds of thousands of Indians being healed of all ailments haven't been confirmed by independent agencies. Her Majesty's Government declined to comment on the status of the Crown Prince, who was present and presumably affected, but…"

"...and the reverend called the event in India 'a hoax and a transparent attempt to deceive the faithful with trickery and sorcery', claiming that 'only God can heal people, and no heathen would receive His grace'. He also called on 'all true Christians' to be on guard against witchcraft, and…"

"...an ambulance had to be called for a self-declared witch who hurt herself repeatedly attempting to cast a spell that supposedly required her own blood. A request for clarification whether or not this was real magic has not yet been answered by the Etherians, but we'll keep…"

"...and while the government declined to comment, experts are concerned about the Etherians' use of orbital bombardment in response to a terrorist attack. Will other countries suffer the same fate? Will we see city blocks melting under a hail of laser fire from space in response to a bomb threat? Does the military have the capability to respond to or prevent such attacks? The public has a right to know, and here at…"

"...of the Vatican declined to comment on the issue and…"

"...more than a dozen were killed when the military fired on the mob attacking the Indian embassy…"

"...reports of soldiers exchanging fire at the border in Kashmir have not been confirmed yet, but the militaries of both countries have been put on alert, and…"

"...far, there have been no confirmed reports of magic despite the Etherians' claims, so there is growing doubt that…"

"...the Indian government hasn't released any casualty numbers yet, but hundreds of soldiers were stationed at the destroyed base, so conservative estimates…"

"...in Tehran claimed that the fire that destroyed an entire apartment building was caused by magic and not negligence, stating that a suspect had already been arrested and would…"

"...the number of suicides by people afraid that the return of magic would imperil their souls might be low overall, but our government cannot ignore this. These people need help, and we demand…"

"...and shrines to She-Ra have already been erected at various locations, even outside the National Capital Region, as grateful people offer their prayer in thanks. However, we have received reports that there have been disputes over the question of whether She-Ra, the Princess of Power, is a goddess in her own right or the latest incarnation of an established goddess such as Shitala Mata or Parvati, and…"

"...the Shinto temples saw far more visitors than expected following the events in India, although no magic has yet been confirmed…"

"...a sangoma claiming to be able to heal has caused a riot in Capetown, forcing the authorities to intervene…"

Jack O'Neill shook his head. The world was going crazy over magic. And over the orbital bombardment that the Etherians had conducted - the Pentagon was in an uproar. He snorted. The brass really shouldn't be surprised; SG-1 had told them what a single Ha'tak could do, and the Etherians had tons of ships that, according to Carter, outclassed a Ha'tak. And yet, it had taken an actual orbital strike for the generals to take it seriously? The politicians were worse, though. Some were already demanding that the United States start building spaceships right now.

And all because a bunch of terrorists managed to take over a military base at the worst possible moment. He felt a bit guilty about that - he had mentioned that possibility when he had talked about security with the Etherians, but he had considered it a very low risk. Teach me to overestimate the Indians, he thought. Well, that couldn't be helped now. The Etherians had revealed their military power - part of it - and what magic could do. And the world wasn't exactly ready for it.

"...and here, in Salem, hundreds of witches are celebrating the return of magic with a broom race. Although, apparently, the start has been delayed while the coven organising the race is debating whether or not pointy hats or helmets should be worn. Until they sort it out, we'll be watching the curse competition going on. Ugh! I just stepped on a frog!"

He blinked at the latest segment. What the hell? That was… Jack narrowed his eyes. "OK, who's the joker who put up Saturday Night Live on the screen?" he yelled through the control room.

One of the new Warrant Officers spoke up: "Sorry, sir! The algorithm must have selected this because of the magic keyword."

Jack glanced at Carter.

"There are search algorithms, sir, but the final selection is made by an officer," she answered his unspoken question.

Which meant that someone had either thought it would be funny to slip in a comedy show or hadn't noticed that this was a comedy sketch and not an actual news report. Jack hoped it was the former - they could need some laughs right now.

"Colonel O'Neill? Captain Carter?"

Jack turned. That was General Haig's aide. "Yes?"

"Your presence is requested."

Oh, damn! Just what he had been waiting for: A meeting with the brass at almost midnight.

Jack sighed.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 18th, 1998

"...and that is our estimate of the firepower the Horde frigate brought to bear against the Indian base. Although we cannot say whether or not they have used their maximum firepower or held back to avoid collateral damage. We are tracking the frigates in high and low orbit."

Carter sounded slightly annoyed, in Jack O'Neill's opinion. Not because it was now past midnight, but because she didn't like repeating what she had already reported - or what was obvious to anyone who could read a radar screen. Which, admittedly, wasn't everyone. Still, she usually hid her annoyance better. She must be tired as well.

"How much time will we have to react should they decide to strike at Stargate Command?"

Or just fed up with Sidorov's paranoid questions.

"None, General," Carter replied. "By the time our sensors register their weapons firing, they have already struck the surface."

"I mean, how quickly can they move into a firing position?" The Russian glared at her.

"That depends on the angle from which they want to fire downwards and their position relative to us. A few minutes at most." Carter was using her 'I want to roll my eyes at you' voice - Jack was very familiar with it.

"And we're not going to sound the alert every time they pass overhead or appear on the horizon. I, for one, like to sleep sometime," General Petit added with a grin.

Carter smiled as well, even though, as far as jokes went, that one had been old when Jack had been born.

"We don't have the capability to stop the Etherians from striking any spot on Earth," General Li summed up what everyone with half a brain would have known on the day the Etherians showed up.

“Yes, General,” Carter confirmed.

“Thank you, Captain Carter,” General Haig said. “This matches our own estimate.”

Jack refrained from sighing loudly. Was this just a cover-your-ass meeting? Did they need SG-1’s official statement to inform their respective governments?

“With that settled,” the limey went on, “there remains the question of magic.”

Jack clenched his teeth. That really wasn’t a subject he wanted to talk about at midnight. Or at all.

“I am afraid that I am no expert on magic, General,” Carter tried to avoid this.

“You’re the best we have, Captain,” Haig retorted. “You have the most experience with magic and magitech at Stargate Command.”

Or on Earth, Jack added for himself.

“Yes, sir.”

“So… is there a way to tell whether magic was restored to Earth or not?” General Li asked.

Carter frowned. “The Etherians said so, sir.”

Sidorov scoffed. Loudly.

Jack narrowed his eyes at the Russian. “In my experience, they wouldn’t lie about this,” he said. “And why would they lie in the first place?”

“They could attempt to deceive us into believing that magic has returned, making us waste time and money trying to control it while leaving us unable to defend ourselves against their magic!”

Jack sighed. Yes, the Russian general was as paranoid as ever. “As we just concluded, we are already unable to defend Earth against their fleet, General.”

Hammond was frowning at him, but Jack didn’t care. Carter was his subordinate. She wouldn’t have to face inane questions from a paranoid Russian if he could help it.

“That would be an open attack, which would reveal their aggression,” Sidorov spat. “But with magic, they could strike far more subtly. Without magic of our own, we cannot defend against that!”

Well, that was theoretically possible, but the Etehrians wouldn’t even dream of doing that - Jack knew them.

“Without restoring magic, the Etherians are limited to magitech, minor inherent effects such as Entrapta’s hair control and Adora’s powers,” Carter cut in. “They cannot use teleportation or spells.”

“That’s what they claim!”

“General.” Haig didn’t sound annoyed, but his meaning was clear, and the Russian glared at him before leaning back with a huff and crossing his arms over his chest. Haig looked at Carter. “But can you confirm that we currently have no way to detect whether or not Earth has magic?”

“Except for observing a magical effect that is not the result of magitech, no sir.”

“Ah.” Haig nodded.

Petit spoke up: “And what can you tell us about the ‘healing’ Adora did, Colonel O’Neill? According to your file, you were healed by her.”

Jack clenched his teeth for a moment, remembering the moment he had almost died and was healed. Then he pushed the

memories away and shrugged. “She points her sword at you, and magic heals you.”

“A few more details would be appreciated, Colonel.” The Frenchman kept smiling at him.

“I’m sorry, but those details are classified.” Jack smiled back. “That happened before the United Nations took control of Stargate Command.” Hammond didn’t look happy but wasn’t frowning at Jack, he noted.

“And you can’t or won’t elaborate on the detailed effect said healing had on you,” Haig said.

Jack spread his hands. “Sorry, sir.”

“From the information that we gathered so far, the healing magic is not limited to specific injuries and doesn’t seem to discriminate,” General Li said. “You are remarkably fit for your age, Colonel.”

“Good living,” Jack replied with a fake smile. So, they knew about that.

“Is there any way we could ask the Etherians to duplicate this feat at Stargate Command, should we suffer casualties?” General Haig asked. “Or would they be willing to restore the health of soldiers who have been medically discharged?”

Adora would heal pretty much everyone in need, Jack was sure of that. But her friends wouldn’t let her heal everyone and burn out. “I don’t know, sir,” he replied.

“I think her services will be in high demand,” General Petit stated the obvious.

And a lot of people would probably regret not having attended the event in India. Still… this was a problem for the Etherians.

Petit seemed to be about to say something else, but the door was opened, and an aide stepped in. “I’m sorry for the interruption,

sir," he told Haig. "But I think you should see the latest news from the BBC." He barely waited for the general to nod before pointing a remote at the screen in the meeting room.

"...reporting directly from Stonehenge, where the police have had to disperse a crowd of people wishing to see magic return, we haven't noticed anything unusual so far, yet we… What's that? The stones are glowing. They are glowing! Is this a trick? I don't see any spotlights, and… yes, the light is coming directly from the stones, as the shadows prove. Oh, here are the police coming towards us…"

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, October 18th, 1998

"The United Nations are holding a special session to discuss 'the incident involving orbital bombardment' and invited us to attend and answer questions."

Adora frowned at Glimmer's words. "They don't want to talk about magic?" That had been the topic the United Nations had wanted to talk about for weeks, after all.

"That's the subject of another special session," her friend replied. "But they apparently want to talk about us blowing up terrorists first." She would know - she'd been talking to diplomats since she had woken up.

"And an Indian army base," Catra, sitting next to Adora in Darla's lounge, added. "Don't forget that."

Glimmer clenched her teeth. "The Indian Prime Minister said they understood our decision."

"That doesn't mean that he liked it," Catra shot back. "They lost too many soldiers to just forget it."

Adora nodded in agreement. You couldn't just ignore such losses. Those soldiers had families. Friends.

“They were already being killed by the mutineers,” Glimmer retorted. “We had no choice.”

“Yes. But not everyone will see it that way,” Bow said. “Some journalists complain that we didn’t ask the Prime Minister before firing on the base.”

Adora had watched the same news. But Bow had been compiling the news from various channels.

Glimmer snorted. “Most of them are trying to use this to attack the Indian government so they can replace it. And what if we had asked and he wouldn’t have given permission fast enough to react? Or not at all? They would have blamed us for the massacre those guns would have caused. And if we had shot at the base anyway, we would have made the Prime Minister and his country look powerless.”

“They are powerless,” Catra said.

“Yes, but it would be rude to rub their noses in it.” Glimmer shook her head.

“We were rude anyway, though,” Bow said. “There was no good solution.”

“It could have been worse,” Glimmer said. “At least from the military angle,” she added with a glance at Adora.

Right. Adora closed her eyes and sighed. The orbital bombardment was only one part of their problems. The other part was Earth’s reaction to magic. To magical healing. To She-Ra.

“Speaking of magic…” Bow trailed off, and Adora didn’t need to open her eyes to know he was grimacing.

“How many want me to heal them?” she asked, slumping forward.

“Many,” Bow told her. “There are complaints that we acted unfairly by healing Indians and demands that we repeat the healing in

every country.”

“What?” Catra hissed. “Who’s demanding that?”

“Mostly individuals being interviewed,” Bow said. “We haven’t received formal requests.”

That was good. Adora couldn’t heal everyone - and she couldn’t repeat what she had done n India. The magic she had used had been part of the blocked magic. “We need to tell them that I can’t use that kind of magic normally.”

“Yes,” Catra agreed. “Too bad we can’t tell them that you can’t heal at all.”

Adora sighed again. She couldn’t heal everyone - she knew that. It was impossible. There were simply too many people on Earth. Too many sick and dying people. She could heal some, though. But how to pick who got healed and who didn’t? It was unfair to only heal a few lucky ones, but to not heal anyone at all sounded… wrong.

“Well, once their own sorceresses learn how to heal people, that shouldn’t be a problem any more,” Entrapta said.

“That will take years,” Glimmer pointed out. “And we don’t know how that works with Earth’s magic.”

“Well, we know they have some magical sites and probably items,” Entrapta said. “There are glowing stones in England! They aren’t runestones, I checked - that would have been neat.”

“It also would have made us look like liars after Glimmer told them that magic won’t result in princesses ruling countries.” Catra snorted.

Glimmer glared at her. “I told them what we knew. And I was right - they don’t have runestones.”

“But they have glowing stones.” Catra grinned.

Adora sighed and gently squeezed her lover's thigh. "And I guess the British want to know what is going there?"

"Yes." Bow nodded. "They are concerned since they don't know what the stone ring - Stonehenge - did before magic vanished."

"They don't have records from the time before?" Glimmer narrowed her eyes.

"Apparently not." Bow shrugged. "There's speculation that the records were destroyed by some of their priests since the stone circle was older than their religion, but no one knows for sure." He sounded almost angry at that.

Well, he was the son of two historians.

"And they want us to come and examine the ring?" Entrapta sounded delighted.

"It won't be the only such site," Bow pointed out. "They might expect us to examine every magical location on Earth."

And that would take too much time, probably. Not that Entrapta seemed to mind - she nodded enthusiastically. "Imagine the data!"

"The United Kingdom is allied with us. So, we can help them without having to help everyone else," Glimmer said. "But we should keep an eye out for other locations. Just in case they turn out to be dangerous."

"Yes," Adora agreed.

"Yes." Bow nodded. "Anyway, so far, there haven't been any confirmed reports of Earth sorceresses working magic. But a lot of unconfirmed reports."

Carta scoffed. "Fools."

Adora frowned. "They might not have forgotten their entire magical tradition. Some lore might have survived." And would be

working now.

“Yes. But I don’t think actual sorceresses would want to reveal themselves right now,” Bow went on with a wince. “Witch hunts have grown worse with magic returned.”

Adora winced as well. She wanted to say they should stop those, but… If they started to intervene for such crimes, where would they stop?

“Any witch hunts organised by a country’s government?” Glimmer asked.

“Well, none that have led to anyone being executed so far,” Bow said.

“The cowards don’t want to risk another orbital strike,” Catra said with a scoff.

“Then it’s not an urgent issue.” Glimmer shook her head. “We have countries calling us returning magic an aggressive act and trying to get the United Nations to condemn us for it.”

“They did that before we returned magic,” Catra pointed out.

Glimmer nodded. “Yes. But now that magic is back, the situation changed. And that we had to destroy the base isn’t helping - some countries claim that’s an act of war.”

“Great.” Catra bared her fangs. “Now that they have realised we can destroy them from orbit, they’re growing even more aggressive? How have those idiots survived all those wars of theirs?”

Adora didn’t point out that Catra hadn’t exactly rolled over either on the occasions that she had been caught on the backfoot during the war. “They’re afraid,” she said instead.

“Well, they should be afraid.”

“We don’t want even more enemies.” Glimmer shook her head. “I’ll be meeting with the United Nations to explain that we just defended ourselves.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “And I can explain about magical healing.”

Glimmer was wincing. Bow as well. And Catra… was shaking her head. “No,” her lover said, “I don’t think you should appear in public on Earth for a while.”

Bow nodded. “Yes. People are putting up shrines and temples for you.”

“And others are burning dolls that look like you,” Catra added.

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again. “I am no goddess!” she spat after a moment.

“Well…” Catra grinned, then grew serious when Adora glared at her. This wasn’t the time for jokes about this!

“Actually,” Bow said, “you do fit the definition of most gods on Earth. Not the most popular god, though.”

“Right now, at least. You look much better than that god,” Catra said.

Adora pinched her thigh in retaliation, making her yelp. This really wasn’t a joking matter!

“Anyway, I think you should limit your visits to Stargate Command,” Bow said. “Or discreet visits to other places. Nothing official.”

Glimmer nodded. “The Swiss sounded very concerned when they asked if you planned to visit the United Nations.”

Great. Adora clenched her teeth. Because of that stupidity, she couldn’t even help Glimmer sort out the mess she had caused?

“Or you can help Sam and us working with magitech!” Entrapta suggested. “We should be creating a magic scanner - a scanner to detect magic.”

“That should lay some of the irrational fears about magic to rest,” Hordak said.

Before Adora could say anything in response, Darla patched a call through to the screen in the lounge.

“Your Divine Highness!”

It was Priest. Adora wanted to scream. “Priest,” she managed to reply while he was bowing. “This isn’t another request for a preemptive strike against those countries that don’t like us, is it?”

“Ah, no, Your Divine Highness.” Priest beamed at her. “Your command was as clear as it was gracious. No, this is a request to help Earth in this time of crisis! In your divine name, of course.”

Adora blinked. “What help… what do you want to do?”

“Now that the humans have finally also seen the light and are worshipping Your Divine Highness, we wish to help your new faithful!” He nodded. “You asked us not to deploy the Holy Legion to convert the humans - peacefully, of course! - for political reasons, but surely, now that they have seen the light and are spreading your holy message themselves, the situation has changed?”

Adora managed not to scream. But it was a near thing.

*****

The Magic Question Part 5

Stonehenge, Wiltshire, United Kingdom, Earth, October 19th, 1998

"Welcome to Stonehenge! I'm James Mason, and this is Major Smythe-Cranston."

The British official - in tweed like the cliche - looked more cheerful than Samantha Carter had expected someone to look faced with an unidentified magical phenomenon. Perhaps he was just relieved that help had arrived to find out what was going on. At least the officer next to him looked properly stiff when he nodded at them.

"Thank you," she told them.

"We're so happy to be here!" Entrapta said, her hair waving. "This is so interesting! The first expression of native Earth magic!" She blinked. "Well, the first that we know off! I can't wait to analyse everything here!"

"You don't have something like it on Etheria?" Mason asked.

"Nothing that looks like it - but depending on *what* it is, we might have something similar. Although we won't know exactly what until we finish our examination. At least I think we can exclude the possibility that this is an ancient superweapon's charging chamber - the readings don't match at all."

Mason's smile turned rather brittle, and the major tensed even more. "I'm happy to hear this. I wasn't aware this was a possibility."

"Well, it's theoretically possible but unlikely. Even if Earth had a magical superweapon, it would need a long time to charge," Entrapta went on. "I bet this is something very different."

"Ah… the most prevalent theory, before the return of magic, was that it was an ancient astronomical observatory or a religious site," Mason said.

"That would be boring." Entrapta cocked her head with a slight pout. "It would be far more interesting if it were some portal or beacon related to another dimension!"

"We'll inform you as soon as we find out anything," Sam told the two men. "Unless you have anything else to discuss…?"

"No, I think we're set here," Mason said. "We'll be at the local headquarters if you need anything. You can reach us over the radio, I believe."

"Yes." Sam watched them leave. Obviously, they didn't want to remain any longer on site as they had to. Or they had orders to leave the Etherians to their work.

And speaking of work, it was time to unload their instruments. Sam followed Entrapta up the ramp to pick up the scanners and other gear.

If Sam needed a reminder of how much her life had changed in the last three months, it would be the fact that as a member of the United Nations Stargate Command, she was part of an Etherian mission to England on behalf of Her Majesty's Government to investigate Stonehenge for its magical properties. And, of course, that a few hundred police officers, as well as two companies of British soldiers, had cordoned off the entire area to keep thousands of civilians from storming the place.

"I miss the secrecy," she mumbled as she stepped out of the shuttle.

"What?" Entrapta paused at the bottom of the ramp.

"Nothing," Sam replied. She looked at the line of soldiers and police in the distance. "Just…"

"Oh, we should be safe here," Entrapta said. "We have six frigates overhead, and Darla should also soon be on the way from Geneva." She frowned. "I don't know why Glimmer had to attend the United Nations session about orbital bombardment. Hordak volunteered to answer any technical questions they had."

"I think it's not just technical questions that they want answered," Sam told her as she arrived at the bottom of the ramp as well.

"Oh? But we already told them all about our rules of engagement," Entrapta said. "Who would expect us not to defend ourselves?" Before Sam could answer that question, she went on: "Of course, technically, we were defending the people attending the ceremony since even in the worst case, we were pretty safe thanks to Emily's shield, but I think that's covered as well." She shrugged.

"I think people didn't expect how you would defend yourself," Sam said.

"That's weird. We told them about the ships. And that they have the capability to fire from orbit at targets on the ground. And they had your report as well covering the use of Naquadah-enhanced bombs, where we used lasers to leave a message in the ground."

Sam remembered that. She sighed. "My report was classified, I believe." Not that everyone who should read her reports did it with the attention they deserved, anyway.

"Oh. I forgot about that." Entrapta sighed as well. "How are people supposed to make decisions if they lack the data to fully understand the situation?"

"People rarely have all the information they need for their decisions," Sam replied. "So, they make the best decisions they can think of. Or should." She hesitated a moment. "And not everyone has the same view of a situation. Some people will value short-term benefits over long-term benefits. Or consider harming their own people acceptable if they personally profit."

“Well, they shouldn’t get elected in that case. Or reelected,” Entrapta said. “Isn’t that the advantage of a democratic system? That you can replace such leaders without a coup?”

Sam sighed again. “Not every voter knows enough to make an informed decision.” You almost never had the complete picture of a situation, anyway.

“Oh.” Entrapta frowned. “That seems like a pretty bad flaw of the system.”

“On the other hand, without a democracy, you don’t even have the option to peacefully remove a leader who values their own profit more than their people.” Sam managed not to scowl. There were reasons that monarchies had been replaced with democracies.

“That’s true as well,” Entrapta said, nodding.

Sam reminded herself that Entrapta wasn’t one to argue a point if she thought it was supported by logic and data.

“So… let’s set up our scanners. Glimmer and the others should arrive shortly,” Entrapta said. “Emily, are you hooked up to our sensor network?”

The bot beeped affirmatively.

“Great! So, we’ll be very safe here.” Entrapta walked over to the outer stone ring.

Sam followed her. In daylight, the stones were barely glowing, but it was still noticeable. At least it wasn’t harmful radiation, as their scan from orbit had shown. Just normal light with a blue tint. Of course, that didn’t mean the site was harmless - if the light was of magical origin, and their scans had also hinted strongly at that, then anything could be possible here - no one really knew what Earth magic could and would do.

For a moment, Sam wished the Colonel were present. He had wanted to come, but he had been stuck in meetings all day. And with the Etherians present, and the Colonel's lack of magical skill or experience, he wouldn't have been of any use here. Despite his talent for magic, as far as they knew.

Sam wasn't sure how she felt about that. The Colonel was one of the best officers she knew. Having him spend his time learning magic - provided they found a teacher or sources - would leave Stargate Command bereft of his experience and leadership. On the other hand, of those she would trust with magic, he was at the top of the list. But it was his decision - or should be.

She started setting up the crystal array for a scanner while Entrapta did the same on the other side of the ring. Shortly before they had finished, Emily announced the arrival of Darla - Sam knew those signals by heart now.

And here came Darla, engines lighting up as she came to a stop above them. After hovering for a moment - probably to scan the area for threats - she started descending.

Sam noticed the ship's force fields expanding slightly to cover the entire site before the ramp was lowered. Unless someone had buried explosives underneath them - and somehow fooled their scanners - they were now safer than anywhere else on Earth.

Then the rest of the Etherians appeared, walking down the ramp to join them. Catra was in the lead, followed by Glimmer and Bow. Catra was looking around as she approached them. "No welcoming committee?" she asked, ears twitching.

"We talked to them already and asked them to give us space to set up without disrupting our work," Entrapta told her. "So, they're waiting with the soldiers there." Her hair pointed towards a few tents thrown up near trucks and APCs.

"Ah." Catra nodded, then turned around and yelled: "No one's here to ask you for healing, so get your butt down here!"

Sam blinked. What…?

Then Adora - blonde hair hidden beneath a wide hat and wearing a long coat - appeared at the top of the ramp.

"It's her disguise," Catra answered Sam's unspoken question.

"She was bothered in Geneva for healing by the same people who were angry with us for defending ourselves," Glimmer added. "Damn hypocrites."

"Well, they weren't the exact same people who actually accused us of trying to invade and conquer Earth," Bow said. "Just people who worked there."

"And the dummy healed them." Catra scoffed.

"I couldn't just not heal them - it took me less than a minute." Adora pouted at them. "And they were deadly ill."

"And now more people think they just have to ask you and get healed," Catra shot back.

Bow raised his hands. "It happened. And I think none of us would walk past people dying if we could help them."

Adora nodded, as did Glimmer - though the latter was frowning. And Catra scoffed again.

"Oh, but you wouldn't do it either!" Entrapta chimed in with a smile, her hair tendril patting Catra on the head for about a second before the catwoman shrugged it off.

"But now everyone will think they just have to meet you and get healed!" Catra repeated. "Even on diplomatic meetings!"

"Well, we can just teleport in and out now," Glimmer said. She grinned. "I so missed that!"

"Just don't teleport here before we've finished analysing the magic effect," Entrapta told her.

Sam knew she shouldn't, but she couldn't help herself - she was too curious. "So, what was the meeting's result?"

Catra snorted. "They couldn't come to a decision."

Glimmer frowned at her. "The United Nations decided not to condemn us for defending ourselves. The motion to do so failed to pass. That's a difference."

Catra shrugged. "Same thing."

Well, Sam had expected that. Between the allies of the Etherians, the prospective and hopeful allies and the countries who didn't want to provoke a power that could lay waste to their forces without taking any risk, the odds that there would be a majority were very slim, even discounting the almost certain veto in the Security Council.

"We still have to return to talk about 'the magic question'," Catra said

She was making air quotes. Was that a sign of Earth's popular culture being adopted by the Etherians? Sam made a mental note to mention it to Daniel. He expected such cultural adaptions. "I doubt the outcome of that will be different," she said. Too many countries saw magic as a way to even the odds against technologically superior rivals.

"Let's hope so. And let's hope they don't invite all their sick and wounded for Adora to heal," Catra said. "I bet some ambassadors are already thinking about selling spots."

"Catra!" Glimmer scoffed. "We're talking about high-ranking diplomats!"

"Exactly."

“Let’s analyse the magic here,” Adora spoke up. She was eyeing the cordon around them, Sam noticed.

If those people decided to push, Sam doubted that the police and soldiers could hold them back. And despite their reputation, the British could be very unruly.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “We’ve placed a crystal array to enhance our scanners!”

“And I can now cast a few spells to help us identify what kind of magic this is,” Glimmer added, raising her staff.

Sam made another mental note that it seemed the staff wasn’t a piece of magitech, but probably what Entrapta had called a focus when she had mentioned magic tools. Or maybe Glimmer hadn’t used her staff so far because she wanted to appear less threatening. After the orbital bombardment, a mere staff wouldn’t matter any more, of course.

Then Sam focused on the readings from their scanner. That was… She frowned and did another scan, compared the data… She had to run another scan!

“It looks like a minor healing effect,” Entrapta said, sticking her head under Sam’s arms to stare at the screen.

“Like the one in the jungle?” Catra asked, tensing up.

“Not like it. Similar, but since this is healing magic, not an unguided regeneration effect, there shouldn’t be any zombies,” Entrapta said.

Sam nodded. “Yes.” She had already scanned for such results - to her relief, the small mammals and insects in the area didn’t show any effects like those that they had observed in Honduras.

“So, is this a healing site?” Catra asked, stretching her arms over her head.

"It might have been one," Sam replied. "But if the stones had been glowing in the past, we should have had records of that, I believe."

"Are you sure?" Bow asked. "From what I found out, a lot of records didn't survive various catastrophes. And purges."

"The glowing might be a result of magic returning after so long. The enchantments might be slightly overloaded," Glimmer said. "Or something broke with the missing stones."

"Or the stars aren't aligned. Or are aligned. The stones were placed in accordance with astronomical observations, after all." Entrapta beamed. "We need more data!"

Could Earth's magic - Earth's magic traditions - be relying on constellations? Sam hoped it wasn't the case. The thought that astrology might be based on actual magic was almost too much to bear…

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Whitehall, London, United Kingdom, Earth, October 19th, 1998

"...and that's the data we used for our conclusions."

Catra watched the others' reactions to Entrapta's presentation. Most of the members of the British Government - Her Majesty's Government, she corrected herself, even though it was more the other way around - who were present seemed to be relieved that they weren't sitting on an Earth version of the Heart of Etheria. Most but not all. A few were almost disappointed.

The Prime Minister, though, smiled. "Thank you very much for your help."

"Oh, you're welcome!" Entrapta beamed at him. "It was a very interesting examination. We now know more about Earth magic.

Although it's too bad that the site isn't a portal to other dimensions. That would have been even better!"

"Yes." Sam nodded. "It was very informative. Especially with the increasing number of similar reports."

"Well, at least most of the supposedly haunted locations didn't show up," the Home Secretary commented with a laugh. "We can handle a few prehistoric magical sites. Especially if they are just healing places."

"We would have to check all of them to be sure of that," Sam told him.

"And once this gets out, there will be a lot of people pressuring us to let them visit Stonehenge," the Prime Minister said.

"And a lot of disappointed people once they realise it's not a stone version of Adora." Catra scoffed.

"Ah… What exactly does the, ah, magic there do?" That was the Health Secretary.

"It's a weak healing effect. You recover faster if you're resting there," Glimmer explained.

"Just recovering faster? Or will you heal from conditions that would not improve without treatment?" The Health Secretary looked intrigued rather than disappointed.

"The latter," Glimmer replied. "But it's not very powerful. You'd have to stay a long time to get healed from a serious condition. Although casting heal magic would be improved as well."

"We'll have people camping there. And fighting each other for a spot on the ground." The Home Secretary wasn't laughing any more. "This is a disaster."

"We could transfer the site to the NHS," the Health Secretary said.

“That won’t keep people away - quite the contrary.”

Catra nodded in agreement. People would want magic healing. Who wouldn’t? But the more options they had, the less they would bother Adora.

“Then we need trained, ah, sorceresses, as soon as possible.” The Health Secretary wasn’t looking at them, but Catra knew the comment was aimed at them. Not very subtle.

“We can’t yet tell what kind of instructions will work best for your sorceresses.” Glimmer said. “And which magical traditions are the best option.”

“We haven’t found actual sorceresses on Earth. Not yet,” Bow added. “You need the talent to work magic.”

“But using this as a blueprint, we could probably create magitech devices that heal,” Entrapta suggested. “Well, we would have to avoid the zombie side effects.” She scrunched her nose. “That’s probably what the First Ones were doing with their prototype. But we should be able to build something that doesn’t turn everyone nearby into zombies. I think.”

“Zombies?” the Prime Minister asked.

“That’s what you call mindless aggressive regenerating people, right?” Entrapta smiled.

“Err, yes.”

“Then zombie it is!”

Sam muttered something about the Colonel Catra didn’t catch.

“I would be glad if we could avoid creating zombies.” The man looked quite queasy.

“Me too!”

The Health Secretary coughed. "Would the current effect at Stonehenge be enough to heal disabling diseases and conditions? One of our most brilliant scientists is suffering from a paralysing disease that is robbing him of the ability to move and talk."

They meant Hawking. The name had come up several times when they were discussing how to reveal magic and healing magic. And now, with magic exposed…

Adora gasped. "I'll heal him right away!"

Catra didn't miss how the Prime Minister and others smiled. She was sure they had planned that.

"We can't take her anywhere," she mumbled.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 19th, 1998

Jack O'Neill was looking at the FNGs train on the field - melee combat this time, with bayonets, knives, Entrenching tools and staffs - but he wasn't really focusing on them. They were good enough anyway; the other countries hadn't sent desk jockeys. Though the Russian with an axe had been a little worrying. Jack was just here to supervise, anyway; he wasn't here as an instructor. And he had other things on his mind. Like Carter.

Jack didn't like it if his team went into danger without him. He trusted them, of course - even Daniel had learned to be a bit cautious, and he could talk his way out of trouble almost as often as he could get into trouble. And Teal'c and Carter were amongst the most skilled soldiers he knew.

But he was their commanding officer. Their leader. If they were in danger, it was his duty to be with them. He shouldn't be staying behind, safe at the base, while Carter went and examined a glowing stone ring that was under siege by thousands of crazy people. Even if she was with Entrapta. Especially if she was with

Entrapta, he corrected himself. The woman was undoubtedly almost as smart as Carter but didn't have half the common sense of Daniel.

At least nothing had happened, and they were now talking to the British government. And even if the limeys botched things, the rest of the Etherians would step in. With magic restored, Glimmer could now teleport.

He sighed. That was also a security risk. At least they had already implemented revised security protocols after the encounter with the Asgard and their transporter.

The instructor in charge called for a break - without glancing at Jack to check, Jack noted approvingly - and the groups broke apart. Jack kept an eye on the axe guy; the Russian looked a bit too happy swinging the thing around. And on Lenkova, who had been walking towards the snack line but diverted and was now making a beeline towards Jack.

"Vladimir is a good soldier."

So that was his name. Of course the woman would have noticed his attention. Jack shrugged. "I didn't know Russia trained soldiers in axe combat."

"We don't," she replied. "Vladimir grew up in Siberia in a logging family."

"His brawls with his siblings must have been a bloody affair."

She giggled at that, which made her suddenly look younger. Not any less dangerous, of course. He kept his eyes on her face, not her shirt. Not that her face wasn't attractive either.

"He's a good comrade. Helps out everyone in need," she said.

"And splits heads and logs, depending on what's on the menu." Jack snorted once.

“Yes.” She was still smiling. “Although you seemed a little distracted today.”

There was no point in denying it - that would only make him look foolish. “There’s a lot happening on Earth,” he said. “Riots, witch hunts, two nuclear powers ready to go to war with each other…”

She scoffed. “India and Pakistan have been at war before.”

“Circumstances were different back then,” Jack shot back. There hadn’t been any aliens or magic.

“Wouldn’t the Etherians stop a nuclear exchange?”

“They said they wouldn’t interfere,” Jack reminded her.

“Politicians and diplomats say a lot,” she retorted with a more cynical grin. “But you know them personally; would they let a nuclear war happen?”

That was a good question. “I don’t know,” he said. He was pretty sure Adora wouldn’t let millions die. But would the fleet be able to intervene in time? Were they even looking out for nukes?

“Well, let’s hope we don’t find out the hard way,” she said.

He could agree with that.

“But was that the reason you were distracted?” She cocked her head, her hair - longer than Carters - touching her shoulder and drawing attention to her tank top. “Or were you worried about Captain Carter?”

He narrowed his eyes. What did she know?

She smiled in return. “I heard she was investigating magical places with the Etherians. The last time you did that, you had to fight zombies, right?”

Jack was, once more, reminded how much he hated that their files were now almost public knowledge. “I didn’t know you had the security clearance to read those files.”

“I didn’t read them. But that there was a zombie invasion is public knowledge.”

He wasn’t sure if he could believe her. But she was right about people knowing about zombies - he had even heard, through the grapevine, that some Hollywood people wanted to shoot a movie about the mission. Still… the woman was a Russian spy. So he shrugged. “She’s with the foremost experts on magic; they’ve dealt with worse things.”

He half-expected her to ask what things the Etherians had dealt with, but Lenkova was too skilled for that. “Do you worry about every soldier under your command?”

“Yes.” Of course he did! Well, there were a few exceptions from his time in Special Forces.

“So, you’d be worried about me when I go on my first mission?” She was grinning again.

Jack bared his teeth and said in a flat voice: “You’d be a soldier under my command.”

She nodded and smiled again. “I hope we’ll go on a mission before you are transferred.”

“Transferred?” What had she heard?

“I read newspapers. America is close to finally passing the laws the aliens demand,” she explained.

Constitutional amendments, but he wasn’t Daniel; he didn’t feel the need to correct her.

“So, once you are allied with the Etherians, you will certainly be transferred to an active combat command.”

Ah, that. He shrugged. “I can’t fathom what the brass will do. After all, I spent years in deep-space radar telemetry.” The former cover story for Stargate Command.

Lenkova laughed at that. It sounded honest.

But she was a Russian spy. And under his command, not that that mattered.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, October 20th, 1998

Adora took a deep breath. She could do this. She had prepared for this. She had rehearsed this. She just had to be firm. Firm and friendly.

Nodding, she said: “Open a channel to Priest, Darla.”

The ship did as ordered, and a moment later - Third Fleet never let her wait - Priest appeared on the big screen on Darla’s bridge.

“Your Divine Highness! How may your faithful serve you?” He bowed so quickly, Adora didn’t see his expression until he rose again, a wide smile on his face.

“I have considered your request to visit Earth,” she said. He perked up. “I feel, in the current circumstances, it wouldn’t be advisable.”

And his face fell. He looked worse than Wrong Hordak had looked before he recovered from getting disconnected from Prime’s mental network. “But Your Divine Highness…”

“The political situation on Earth is volatile,” she explained. “Many humans are afraid that we’re here to conquer them.”

“But if we wanted to conquer them, we would have done so already! Their defences are nothing against the firepower of even

the flotilla in orbit, much less the Third Fleet, Your Divine Highness!”

Adora sighed. “I know. And they should know.”

“How could they not, after our intervention in India? Were they distracted by the demonstration of your divine might and grace, Your Divine Highness?”

She pressed her lips together for a moment. That hadn’t been one of her finest moments. Although she would do it again in the same situation - she wouldn’t let people die if she could help it. But saying that wouldn’t help here. “They aren’t always rational. Although some fear that the destruction of the base was the first step in a campaign to conquer Earth.”

“They don’t know you, then, Your Divine Highness. Or us.”

She nodded. “Yes. That is why they fear us.” Well, some of the countries would fear them even more if they knew Adora and her friends better. Those who had horrible customs and laws.

Priest nodded. “I see. But if ignorance is the problem, shouldn’t we educate them instead of staying away from them, Your Divine Highness? If they could meet us and talk to us, we could show them that their fears are misguided!” He looked at her with an expression full of hope.

Uh… She managed not to bite her lips. How to tell him that some people on Earth would fear and hate Adora - and Priest and his faithful - even or especially if they knew them better? She hadn’t prepared for that question, but… “Are your people trained in diplomacy?” They weren’t; Adora knew that.

“We have studied the work of those on Earth who spread the word of false gods, Your Divine Highness. Missionaries, they are called.” Priest smiled at her. “We know all about door-knocking!”

“Ah…” He obviously didn’t mean the Goa’uld when he talked about false gods, Adora realised. That could be a bigger problem than

she had feared. “Many people won’t like it if you call their gods false.”

He frowned. “But they do the same, Your Divine Highness. The majority of the population worships single gods and denounces all other gods as false. And doesn’t the freedom of religion protect missionaries?”

Adora almost smiled. “Freedom of religion isn’t granted in every country. Many countries do not respect all religions - or outlaw missionaries.” Not too many prohibited missionaries, actually, but that was a detail.

“Ah!” Priest bowed again. “And yet, aren’t such countries those which need to learn about your divine wisdom the most, Your Divine Highness?”

“We have to respect their laws,” Adora replied. “At least as far as missionaries are concerned,” she quickly added.

“So, our missionaries shall stick to countries where religion is free, Your Divine Highness.”

“I am not a goddess,” Adora said through clenched teeth. She had tried to avoid this.

“You are as humble as you are powerful and wise, Your Divine Highness,” Priest replied, bowing so deeply that she couldn’t tell if he was smiling or smirking.

“I’m really not,” Adora repeated herself.

“Your Divine Highness, we have also studied the gods that are worshipped on Earth - and their deeds. You have healed the sick, let the blind see again and the lame regain their legs. You have struck down the false god who lied to us and oppressed us. You have turned the heart of his Empire into a garden in space. You have freed our souls and cast his soul down into the Abyss. And you have saved not merely one world but all the worlds in the sector. These facts do not lie, Your Divine Highness - you more

than met the standard for divinity on Earth." Priest smiled at her with shining eyes. "You saved us, and you will save everyone from the false gods. It is only just that we will spread the word of you in return, so everyone can bask in your grace."

No, no, no! That was wrong! Terribly wrong! "I don't have a grace!" she snapped.

"Your humility is divine!"

Adora opened her mouth to yell at Priest, then took a deep breath. This was going all wrong! She had wanted to explain to Priest why he and his people couldn't visit Earth to convert people. She could just tell them not to visit Earth, of course. And she was tempted to do so - very much.

But she had talked about this with her friends. What if Priest took this to mean that the people on Earth are to be ignored because they were beyond saving? Or, worse, that Adora didn't want them saved or whatever? You couldn't win a war if a big part of your soldiers thought their allies were traitors or at least ungrateful heathens.

She sighed. "You won't visit a country without permission from that country and from myself or Glimmer as our commander."

"Yes, Your Divine Highness!"

"And you'll stick to short trips." No invasion. Just some sailors going on shore leave. "And not everyone at once."

"Of course, Your Divine Highness. We have to remain ready to fight at your command at a moment's notice!"

Adora couldn't think of anything else. She nodded. "Good." It was anything but good.

"As you command, Your Divine Highness! I will relay your orders at once!" Priest bowed even more deeply.

Adora sighed. Her friends wouldn't be happy about this. Nor would the humans on Earth like this. Well, they'd inform the United Nations about this. And find out which countries would allow such 'visits'.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 21st, 1998

Once, Samantha Carter would have been delighted to see real teleportation in action - and in an environment where she could use all sorts of sensors to take readings to analyse later. But there was such a thing as too much of a good thing. And so, when her lab was lit up with another set of sparkling lights, she didn't even look up - Glimmer had been teleporting every five minutes, sometimes just a few metres in the lab. She must have really missed using her power.

"Sorry, I forgot - did anyone want dessert as well?" the princess asked.

"What dessert is on the menu today?" Entrapta cocked her head, pausing in the middle of working on an improved long-range Geiger counter. Something the world could really use right now, what with two nuclear powers butting heads - Sam knew that the Horde frigates in stationary orbit over the Indian subcontinent could shoot down missiles, but a better early warning system would be great.

"Oh, silly me!" Glimmer laughed and disappeared in another cloud of sparkles, only to reappear five seconds later. "Blue jello and apple cake."

"Oh! I've never tried that combination! Yes, I'd like dessert!"

"Sounds very American. Me too, please!" Iwan added.

"Just the cake," Catra chimed in from the counter she had taken over, not even looking up from her magazine.

“For me too. Just the cake, that is,” Adora, who was apparently content with serving as a pillow for Catra to sprawl over, said, lowering her own magazine. “Thank you!”

“I’ll try the jello,” Bow said.

“Jello,” Hordak grumbled.

“Are you sure you don’t want to try the cake?” Entrapta asked, beaming at him.

“I’ll take the cake as well,” Hordak replied at once - as expected.

“If you don’t like it, we can swap,” Entrapta said as Glimmer disappeared once more. Sam wondered how the mess hall was reacting to the princess popping in and out in short order. If the Colonel were present, he’d tell her about it. With a joke.

But he was supervising the training of the foreign teams in the field again. If you could call them teams already - they were still forming. Not that the Colonel was needed there - he was nominally in command of the teams, but others were training them, and he wasn’t scheduled as an instructor for today. But he said it was a good idea to keep an eye on the foreigners. Sam couldn’t disagree with that, although she would like it if there were fewer rumours about the Colonel having his eye on a particular foreign officer. Not that anything would happen - the Colonel would never start anything with someone in his chain of command.

Sam buried the mixed feelings she had about that just in time for Glimmer to return with a tray full of jello and cake.

“Finally! What did you do, bake the cake yourself?”

“Catra!”

“What?”

“No, I didn’t!”

“Can we do that? I’d like tiny cakes! Oh, but this is good! Try something, Hordak!”

“Hmph.”

“Since you didn’t say anything, I brought you both!”

Sam looked at Glimmer. The princess was holding out the tray with a bowl of jello and a piece of cake left on it. And she was smiling widely, so Sam would feel bad to refuse. Even if she wasn’t overly fond of either dessert. At least not of what passed for it here. Still, she had to eat it now.

And it tasted quite a bit better than expected. Had the French replaced the cooks? Or brought in confectioners? She could imagine General Petit bringing one along; the man liked his personal comforts.

“So, what do you think?” Entrapta asked Hordak.

“It is… adequate.”

“I’ve had better,” Catra added. “But for military food, it’s better than Horde rations.”

“Even rocks are better than Horde rations. Easier to chew, too,” Adora said.

Both laughed at that.

Sam felt herself relax as well. They still had lots of work to do - apart from enhanced scanners for nuclear weapons held ready, they also had dozens of reports of magical sites ‘going active’ all over the world to cover. And reports to write so the brass would realise that Sam couldn’t ‘whip up’ a healing device in her spare time. But she could take a break joking around with the Etherians. Maybe she could convince Daniel to join them in the afternoon - he was still sifting through his stack of books covering myths and fairy tales in an attempt to find working magical spells and traditions.

And maybe the Colonel would join them as well - all of them needed a break, after all.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 23rd, 1998

"...tensions are still high at the Kashmir border, but there hasn't been a shooting incident in two days, which experts say is a sign of increased control by the respective governments over their forces, although it remains unclear how the separatists will react to this. The United Nations have called on all parties to remain peaceful, although China's stance remains unclear, as does the stance of the Etherians, who have three space ships in geostationary orbit over the subcontinent, yet have not voiced an opinion on the matter so far. This leaves the world in doubt whether or not a nuclear war would cause them to intervene or not, which experts have claimed is similar to the United States' stance towards a defence of Taiwan and might be a calculated move to influence both India and Pakistan into negotiations, though…"

Sitting in her - it was hers now - corner in Sam's lab, Catra sighed and flicked the pad off. Bow had done all the work to let their pads access all of Earth's media, and yet there wasn't anything worth watching on. Or if there was, she hadn't found it, and she wasn't about to waste an hour switching channels to find something. If she did it on her pad instead of on a screen, it wouldn't annoy anyone anyway except herself.

"Back in the USSR, we joke that it no matter that we have fewer channels if Americans have dozens of channels and nothing good to watch." Iwan, the Russian spy scientist, smiled at her. "It was good joke, not approved by party, but not enough for gulag."

Catra snorted at the last line. "Sounds like Horde humour," she said before she could help himself.

“Da. I think. Horde much like USSR? Lots of tanks and soldiers, not much good food or fun?”

Catra nodded. “Pretty much, yes.” As cadets, she’d had Adora, but Shadow Weaver had done what she could to ruin everything, and when Adora had left… She sighed. Then Catra had done what she could to ruin everything.

“Bad memories?”

Catra narrowed her eyes. That was a bit blatant. She glanced around. Adora was working with Glimmer on a press release. So much for ‘I’m just coming along so I can visit Earth without getting hounded by petitioners’! Bow and the other tech heads were working on the enhanced Geiger counters - or were that enhanced-enhanced Geiger counters by now? In any case, it was a good opportunity for a spy to gather information. Add his obviously fake bad English he used to make people underestimate him… On the other hand, it wasn’t exactly a secret that Catra had been leading the Horde before… Before. “Yes, bad memories,” she said.

“People in Russia drink to get rid of bad memories, but not work well.”

“Yeah.” Not that Adora would let Catra drink anyway. Carve a few funny lines into a stupid pastel palace wall one time with your claws, and they never let you forget it.

For a moment, the Russian remained silent, looking at whatever he was working on. Then he nodded. “What helps is doing better. Helping helps.”

She snorted, but he had a point, sort of. “Helping can also hurt.” Adora proved that.

“Da. Life is pain, and then you die. Painfully.” He nodded sagely.

She shrugged. Life didn’t have to be painful. Usually, some idiot was responsible for that part. Or a Horde of idiots. Or some

ancient idiot bot trying to make Adora sacrifice herself. But life didn't have to hurt. Not really hurt, at least. You just needed to get rid of the worst idiots.

Iwan went back to working, and Catra switched her pad back on.

"...representants of several religions have voiced their concern about the Etherians intent to send missionaries to Earth, but the government has released a statement that aliens were also protected by the constitutional freedom of religion and that it would not take any steps to prevent Etherian visitors from proselytising. When asked whether or not he would push for reciprocity with regards to Christian missionaries visiting Etheria, the President said that visits to Etheria were currently restricted to military needs and that this question would have to be revisited once civilian travel was possible. He did not say when he expected this state of affairs to change, but…"

Catra shook her head. "It's not us who wants this, but Priest," she muttered. But the crazies were already screaming - sometimes literally - about an alien plot to brainwash the humans to corrupt their souls or something. And missionaries visiting Etheria? She snorted. Good luck trying to convince people that an invisible intangible god existed when you just had to look to the sky and see what She-Ra could do.

They should be more concerned about all the magical places activating, in her opinion. As Bow and Daniel had explained, most of them were holy sites of religions that had been more or less replaced by the current mainstream religions. Depending on how things worked out, they might need every missionary on Earth just to keep up with magic.

Or with Priest's followers.

*****

The Magic Question Part 6

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 24th, 1998

"...and the police was forced to use violence to keep protesters and counter-protesters separated in Washington. Bill?"

"Thank you, Keith. Yes, it's been a bit sticky, but not as bad as it could have been. The number of people protesting the President's decision to allow alien missionaries to visit the country has been much lower than expected, even with the boost the return of magic gave to the anti-magic movement."

"People like magic healing. Who would have thought?"

"Certainly not the good reverend calling for this protest, Keith! Anyway, Washington is quiet again."

"Something that cannot be said for the rest of the world. Daily protests are going on in many countries in the Middle East, and the witch hunts and lynchings in the region continue, although hard numbers are hard to come by. In other news, experts disagree on whether or not we are looking at the start of a new religion in India now that we know that there's already an established Church of She-Ra. And no, that's not an official name, but if our benevolent alien allies would like to use it, I wouldn't request royalties!"

Jack O'Neill tuned the fake laughter out. Why couldn't the mess hall just broadcast CNN instead of this farce? Or the BBC. He didn't need to listen to stupid jokes when things were getting serious. Cracking jokes was his thing, damn it! On the other hand, he probably should be glad that the mess hall TV still broadcasted an American news show instead of a Russian one. Or a French one. He shuddered at the thought.

“Is something wrong?” Daniel asked as he set his tray down on the table. “With the food?”

“No. It’s the news,” Jack replied, nodding towards the screen now showing advertisements.

“What happened this time?” Daniel turned to look at the television.

“It’s not what happened, but how they cover it.”

“Ah.” Daniel nodded. “It’s actually quite interesting how the different TV channels cover the same events. You can make out distinctive social norms by the differences in what is emphasised and what’s dismissed. Why…”

“Daniel, your food’s getting cold,” Jack reminded him.

“Ah, sorry.” His friend started eating, then blinked. “Is it just me, or has the quality of the meals improved?”

“It’s not just you,” Jack told him. “We needed more cooks to cover the influx of new people, and our gallant foreign allies decided to send their own.” And, apparently, decided to show off and send cooks who could hack it in civilian life. The food wasn’t up to fine dining standards - they still had to cook in quantities that meant they couldn’t carefully prepare each meal - but it certainly was better than before.

“Ah!” Daniel smiled. “That’s good news!”

“What’s good news?” Carter had arrived, smiling at them both.

“Good to see that the Etherians didn’t squirrel you away on one of their ships,” Jack joked. It wasn’t as funny as he had planned, though.

Carter’s smile twisted a little. “Well, Entrapta did offer me to move into her lab.”

Jack frowned. Poaching his second in command? Over his dead body!

"Really?"

"Yes. She said it would 'facilitate research'." Carter shrugged. "I told her that I had duties here and could always come visit her."

Jack nodded. Yes. They had their duties on Earth.

"So, what's good news?" Carter asked after a bite from her steak.

"That we've got better cooks," Daniel told her.

"Indeed." For someone his size, Teal'c could be very stealthy. Jack had almost missed his approach.

"As long as they don't serve us crayons…" Jack snorted. He didn't have to explain the joke, which meant he had made it before. Well, some jokes bore repeating.

He was about to finish his own steak when he saw Carter tense up. Glancing over his shoulder, he saw Lenkova approach the table. "Do you mind if I join you?"

What was he supposed to do without sounding rude? She didn't offer a transparent excuse like all her comrades had already eaten or something.

"Not at all! please sit down!" Daniel said with a smile.

Jack managed not to frown at his friend. Daniel was just too friendly sometimes.

Teal'c nodded without saying anything, and Carter… smiled tightly as she nodded. She obviously didn't like Lenkova. But she hadn't said anything before, as far as Jack could recall.

And Lenkova was all smiles. She had ditched the top of her fatigues and was just wearing her tank top, Jack noticed. And she

made very appreciative noises when she tried the food.

"Oh, this is so much better than what we ate back in Russia," she said with a long sigh.

"Yeah, we can hear that," Jack said before he could help himself.

Lenkova blushed in return.

And Carter was openly frowning.

"So, what do you think of this?" Lenkova tried to change the subject by nodding at the TV screen, where the hosts were interviewing another supposed expert on religions.

"...and, so, while technically it falls under the term religion as defined by law, one could argue that it's not a religion but a thinly-veiled attempt to influence the internal politics of the United States. She-Ra is, after all, not a goddess but a leader of the Princess Alliance - it goes without saying that merely calling your party a religion does not make it a religion. And as our past shows, it's perfectly legal to limit foreign propaganda during wartime."

"But, and I am just repeating some of the arguments brought forth by others, why isn't the Church of She-Ra a religion?"

"Well, ah, first, She-Ra herself denies her, ah, divinity. And second, we can all see that she is no goddess. She has magic powers, but that does not make her a divine entity. There is also the lack of any significant history - according to what we know, this 'Church of She-Ra' is less than a year old and composed of formerly brainwashed clones. It might be called a cult, but it's not a religion as the average American understands it."

"The President seems to disagree."

"The government is beholden to the Etherians for military reasons. Of course they cannot afford to oppose this thinly-veiled

attempt to conduct propaganda operations in the United States. So…"

Jack rolled his eyes. At least no one could claim that the United States government controlled the media.

"Ah." Daniel adjusted his glasses with a smile. "That's a very biased opinion, of course. You cannot, as any anthropologist would tell you if asked them instead of a theologist of dubious repute, consider Christianity as the standard for a religion. Human religious traditions are much more diverse. We have ancestor worship, nature spirits being revered, pagan pantheons - although that term is somewhat misleading - and religions that do not have divine figures at all. For many religions, She-Ra would, purely based on her powers, indeed be considered a goddess. In fact, she would compare favourably to some of the classic Greek gods. As would some of her fellow princesses like Perfuma and Mermista. Again, purely based on their magic powers. So, from an anthropologist's perspective, I do not think that the government is in error when treating the Church of She-Ra as a religion." He beamed at Lenkova.

Jack suppressed a sigh. Daniel still had a tendency to go on and on.

Lenkova looked… well, she was frowning a little. "That's very interesting. But I wanted to know what you think of the consequences of this… new development."

"Ah!" Daniel nodded. "Well, it remains to be seen if this new religion can get any traction outside the former Horde fleet and India. Unless Adora starts healing Americans en masse - which I don't think she'll do - I don't see the new religion having much success in the United States. Although the resurgence of magic might change this - a lot of formerly esoteric beliefs might grow more popular provided their magical traditions end up working."

And wasn't that a pretty thought! Maybe Stargate Command would issue healing crystals as standard gear, and intel would be

based on tea leaves reading. And Carter would use crystal balls for her stuff.

“And do you think this will lead to problems?” Lenkova asked.

“It has the potential to be a problem,” Daniel replied at once. “But we’ve been seeing a pushback against the more intolerant religious conservatives for months, in politics and the media as well as public opinion, so I don’t think that the United States will see much more than a few protests against this.”

“I see.” The Russian nodded.

Jack wasn’t quite as optimistic but refrained from commenting.

Then she turned towards him. “You’ve been rather quiet, Colonel.”

Jack noticed Carter frowning again but ignored that for the time being. “Daniel’s the expert,” he said. “Just as Teal’c is the resident authority on Jaffa and Goa’uld and Carter’s Stargate Command’s goddess of technology.”

The frown turned into a scowl. “I’m not a goddess, sir.”

Jack didn’t wince. So, that had been a failed attempt to crack a joke. Even if Lenkova laughed.

“I don’t think it was meant to be taken literally,” she told Carter. “You do have a very impressive reputation, though. Dr Georgovich is singing your praises. Not literally, fortunately - he hasn’t the best singing voice.”

Jack chuckled, but Carter’s scowl deepened. “I am just doing what I can - like all of us here,” She replied, a bit cattily in Jack’s opinion.

Lenkova nodded. “Will you be transferred along with the Colonel when America closes the deal with the Etherians? Will they keep your team together?”

Carter blinked for a moment. “I am not aware of any such orders,” she said. “We are part of Stargate Command.”

That was the technically correct answer. But Carter knew as well as Jack that the United States wouldn’t leave the best friend of the Etherians under the authority of the United Nations.

“Ah, we’ve been working well with the Etherians, so it would stand to reason that they wouldn’t split us up,” Daniel ventured. “Especially considering the way the Etherians fight their wars. With the princesses expected to fight on the frontlines when necessary, and their personal approach to politics, I think all of us will be working closely with them.” He smiled. “So, I don’t see SG-1 being split up!”

Lenkova smiled as well. “It would be a mistake and a shame to split up such a successful team.” With a nod to Jack, she added: “Your team does you credit, Colonel.”

“Thank you. You have a good team as well,” Jack returned the compliment. It was the truth, after all. “You’ll do fine once you’re on your own.” And that they weren’t quite ready yet was also true.

It didn’t seem to bother the woman, though - she beamed at him. “Thank you. Although I hope you will still be available for talks once we’re no longer under your command.”

“Sure.” Jack nodded before he realised how the way Lenkova leaned forward a little added something not entirely professional meaning to her words.

Carter stood up. “Well, it’s time for me to return to the lab.”

Oh.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, October 25th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and please remember: You represent the Alliance! We're here to protect Earth from the Goa'uld. Many people on Earth are afraid of us. They don't know our customs. They don't know us. So, don't scare them, don't bully them, and remain polite and peaceful no matter what they say. Even if they insult me - especially if they insult me. Err… you can, of course, defend yourself if someone attacks you, but don't go overboard. That means no orbital bombardment." Ador blinked. "Not without permission from Alliance Command." She didn't want to sound like a hypocrite, after all - and, in theory, there might be more situations where an orbital strike was the necessary answer.

The dozens of clones standing in formation before her in the frigate's main hangar bowed. "Yes, Your Divine Highness," they said in unison. And smiled.

Adora refrained from wincing even though it sounded very creepy. They acted as if just being near her was the best thing they could think of. As if Adora's mere presence made them happier than anything else. For a moment, she imagined Horde Prime standing in her place - he would have loved this. Had loved it. Except for the lack of orbital bombardment. And the other orders.

And, she added to herself, he probably wouldn't have taken the dark Earth-style suits every clone was wearing well either.

She glanced at Priest, who was wearing a similar suit, just with a more elaborate tie. 'New dress uniforms', he had claimed. Catra had found it funny. Adora less so. Priest was correct that the fleet - in fact, most of the Princess Alliance - didn't have dress uniforms like Earth soldiers had, though Bright Moon had 'parade uniforms', but to pick those suits as uniforms… Well, it was kind of just another part of his 'we proselytise through shore leave' plan. Which she really hoped wouldn't backfire but also didn't want to succeed.

But there wasn't anything else to say that she hadn't already said. Twice, since the clones might be a little too much like Priest. So

she nodded at the clones, then at Priest. “Dismissed. And have fun!”

Priest bowed so deeply, Adora was almost afraid his head would hit the ground, then straightened and addressed the rest. “You heard Her Divine Highness! You represent Her, so conduct yourself accordingly! I do not want to hear any complaints about your behaviour! Now go and enjoy your shore leave!”

The clones saluted him, Bright Moon style. That was a nice change from Horde regulations. Then they bowed to Adora, which made her struggle not to sigh again, before they started boarding the shuttles. All of them seemed very enthusiastic. Beaming. Laughing. Talking to each other. They loved this.

And Adora was left hoping that this wouldn’t cause trouble. At least not a lot.

*****

“So, how are your faithful doing?” Catra greeted Adora when she returned to Darla’s bridge.

“Shouldn’t you know that better than I would?” Adora replied, pointing at the screens on the bridge showing feeds from London, Paris, Berlin and New York.

“They haven’t touched down yet,” Catra said with a grin.

Adora frowned at her. “Why do you think this is funny?”

Catra’s grin widened. “It is funny because it annoys you.”

Adora pressed her lips together. She should have expected that.

Catra lost her grin and smiled ruefully for a moment. She didn’t apologise, though. “And it’s also funny because they’re acting like humans. Right down to the uniforms.”

“Suits,” Adora corrected her.

“Priest defined them as uniforms, so they’re uniforms,” Catra shot back.

“And why is it funny that clones are acting like humans?” Adora wanted to know. It wasn’t funny. Not at all!

“It might make the idiots on Earth realise how stupid they are about their religions,” Catra explained as she shifted in her seat.

Adora sighed. That was a touchy subject. “Earth is very serious about their religions.”

“Only the parts of Earth that we don’t want to have anything to do with,” Catra retorted. “And the same goes for them.”

That was, well… not entirely wrong. But not entirely correct either. “Their pope told everyone that magic wasn’t evil.” That covered at least one of the biggest religions.

Catra scoffed. “And he *didn’t* tell everyone that us loving each other was fine. Speaking for a god that supposedly wants you to love everyone.”

Adora didn’t think Catra - or herself - were reliable sources on Earth’s religions. Or any religion - it wasn’t as if growing up in the Horde had taught them anything about any religion. And Adora hadn’t exactly researched the various religions on Etheria since the war had ended. Perfuma and most of Plumeria worshipped nature, Mystacore worshipped magic… That was about the extent of her knowledge. It just wasn’t something most people talked about. Still… “I just don’t want to be worshipped.”

Catra shrugged again. “Better you than some invisible, silent god that won’t step in when its followers start hurting others.”

Adora’s lover had made that point before. And Adora couldn’t really argue it. But that didn’t mean she liked it, either. “You usually complain if I feel responsible for everyone.”

"Yes." Catra scoffed. "But it's better than the alternative. Imagine if the humans converted the clones!"

Adora shuddered at the thought. That would be a catastrophe!

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, October 26th, 1998

"Chevron Six, encoded!"

"Chevron Seven locked!"

A moment later, the gate activated. Samantha Carter saw the members of the new Stargate team - British this time - wince slightly as the vortex formed before stabilising. Good. That meant they remembered how lethal it was.

But they recovered quickly, the team leader stepping on the ramp, then looking at the command centre.

"Proceed to your destination," General Haig ordered the men, and the team quickly marched through the gate, vanishing from view.

And that was it. Sam's work for this 'acclimatisation mission' was done. She stayed at her post anyway, just in case something came up - even with a routine trip to a known destination which already had a team and temporary base on site, you never knew if something unexpected would happen. It was part of what made Stargate Command such an attractive posting for Sam. Next to being able to advance physics past anything people outside science fiction authors could have imagined a few years ago, of course. And now being able to work with magitech.

And working with people who appreciated her talents and didn't think she had slept her way up or was riding the coattails of a man. Sam had had enough of that to last her a lifetime. As if she'd ever sleep with a superior to advance her career! Just

sleeping with a fellow officer could damage your career, and if you got involved with someone in your chain of command…

She pressed her lips together. This was purely hypothetical. She knew the regulations, and she was a professional soldier. Such things were off-limits, and for very good reasons. The last thing Stargate Command - or any unit involved with the war against the Goa'uld - needed was people getting distracted by relationships, gossip and interpersonal conflicts.

Even the Russians should realise that. Especially the Russians. Certainly some Russian spy posing as a soldier trying to honeytrap the Colonel. Who should really know better than to encourage the woman!

She closed her eyes for a moment and took a deep breath. She was being silly. The Colonel was a professional and knew the Russians better than anyone else in Stargate Command. He wouldn't fall for such a blatant attempt to seduce him. Really, 'I am looking forward to when we're no longer in the same chain of command'? Hah! By that time, the new Stargate Command site would be ready, and the Russian spy would be stuck on the coast of Canada, while SG-1 would be part of whatever expeditionary force the United States would send along with the Etherian fleets.

Sam pushed the thought that SG-1 might end up split up away. She had talked to Entrapta and the others about how the Etherians waged war, and from what she heard, it sounded like SG-1's experience was an almost perfect fit for the kind of operations the Princess Alliance ran. A small group of highly-skilled special forces used to working together spearheading larger operations. Odds were, SG-1 would be kept together, for both political and military reasons.

And if not, a traitorous part of her mind whispered as she ran another check on the gate's status, the Colonel wouldn't be in your chain of command any more…

She pushed that thought away as well.

*****

An hour later, the British team was back, and Samantha Carter was taking a break while a French team was getting ready for their first gate trip. She sipped from a cup of great coffee - General Petit had had the standard coffee makers replaced with civilian-grade models that shamed most coffee shops in Colorado - and looked at the screen in the corner of the control room, where the news was being displayed. At least the news deemed relevant or important for Stargate Command, selected by a team of specialists and put on a loop.

Today, like yesterday, it was focused on the Etherian missionaries, showing two of them walking down a narrow street in… London. "They really look like alien Mormons," General Petit commented as he joined her.

Mormons sent missionaries all over the world, Sam reminded herself. Even to such secular countries as France. "Yes, sir," she agreed.

"But they look slightly stiff," the general went on. "They must be under great pressure, with the eyes of the world on them. And the eyes of their superiors."

Sam agreed again. Though she wasn't sure if the Horde clones, at least those from Third Fleet, weren't their own worst critics, so to speak - from what Sam had seen of them, they were religious fanatics. And now on a mission from their goddess. At least they weren't wearing sunglasses and organising a concert. She suppressed a snort - this was too serious for that kind of joke.

"Although I doubt that there will be much if any trouble in London or Paris," Petit went on. "Or Berlin."

Sam was tempted to point out that Europe had its fair share of religious fanatics as well but refrained. And not just because the general was her superior, but also because, even taking into account the smaller populations, neither the United Kingdom nor

France or Germany had had nearly as many protests against the 'shore leave' of the clones as the United States had had and were still having. Fortunately, most of those protests were held in places the aliens weren't visiting.

And the last few months had shown a rapid decline of both the influence and visibility of the radical Evangelicals in the country. Though being dropped by pretty much every conservative business and billionaire hadn't been received well by those conservative politicians who hadn't changed their stance on religion. Once the proposed constitutional amendments passed - and Sam had no doubt they would pass - things might get ugly in some places.

She masked her silence with another sip from her coffee and made some appreciative noise.

The General beamed. "I personally selected this coffee maker! It's the best on the market!"

Sam nodded. And probably the most expensive as well. Well, it wasn't her budget to worry about. "It shows," she said. She was about to add some platitude when the screen changed. CNN. Showing police cars. *American* police cars. And a red banner at the bottom.

Breaking news! Alien shot in New York!

*****

North Shore University Hospital, New York, Earth, October 26th, 1998

Catra didn't bother to hide her mood, snarling as she sprinted down the hallway after Adora. One of the clones had gotten shot by some Earth nutcase. And, of course, Adora had dropped everything to rush to the clone.

Well, his condition was critical according to what they had been told, and Earth hospitals and doctors had no experience treating

clones, and if the guy died, things would probably get ugly. Uglier. Priest had already been talking about making the man a 'martyr' or something. But still - running through a hospital like this wasn't exactly 'good optics', as Mr Brown would say.

"Uh… ma'am? This is a…"

Adora brushed past the uniformed guards in front of the door between her and the wounded clone as if they weren't there. Not that they could have stopped her if they had tried - nothing could stop Adora in such a moment. She all but kicked the door open.

Catra still kept an eye on the guards as she passed them - they were armed, after all.

Inside the room, a woman in white clothes - a doctor or nurse - tried to stop Adora. "This is an operating room! You can't just…"

Adora ignored her as well, pointing her sword at the figure on the table, surrounded by startled humans. The nurse shrieked, but the glowing healing magic was already covering the wounded clone.

Moments later, he started to move, or tried to - they had tied him to the table. She-Ra cut him free with two slices of her sword while everyone else backed away. "How are you? Do you still feel pain?"

Catra saw the clone blink before he recognised Adora and his eyes widened. "Your Divine Highness!"

Usually, Adora would flinch at hearing that title, but she was too focused on saving him, Catra noticed. "Do you still feel pain?"

"Uh… No, no! No, Your Divine Highness!" His mouth spread in a wide smile and he was blinking through tears.

Adora curtly nodded, then took a deep breath. "We arrived in time."

"Yeah," Catra agreed. And they had attracted a lot of attention. She pushed her communicator. "Sparkles? We've got him."

"Alright! Coming!"

"Glimmer's on the way," Catra told Adora, who was helping the clone off the table. He still looked like he had had the time of his life instead of nearly dying. "Just have to wait until she finds us."

"Good. Where are his clothes?" Adora asked the humans present.

"Uh… we had to cut them off to prep him for surgery," one of them replied.

"Ah."

"What about his communicator?" Catra asked. That was, well, not really advanced technology, but you didn't leave your comms if you could help it. That was how your communication lines got compromised. Well, that and by Entrapta and Bow hacking into your systems.

"Uh…"

Catra shook her head and turned to glare at the uniformed guards - who had multiplied in the meantime but hadn't dared to enter the room. "Fetch his gear!"

One of them turned to leave, then stopped, glancing at another guard. Probably their leader. Or were those cops? It didn't matter.

"That's evidence for a criminal investigation," the leader said.

Before Catra could tell the idiot what he could do with his 'criminal investigation', another man arrived and snapped at him. "Perkins! Don't try to boss around the aliens with spaceships floating above us!"

"But Chief!"

He ignored him and smiled - although tightly - at Catra and Adora. "I've sent someone to fetch his belongings."

"Thank you!" Adora beamed at him. And then Catra's idiot lover went on: "Was anyone else hurt? They only told us about him."

By the time Glimmer arrived in a cloud of sparkling light - Catra didn't know how many other rooms she had teleported into before reaching them - Adora was already busy healing half the patients in the hospital.

And Catra couldn't help wondering if this had been part of a plan to get her lover to heal people.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, October 26th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So, what exactly happened? The Earth authorities kept saying they were still investigating when I asked them. All of them!" Glimmer asked. And she had talked to every authority she could reach, Catra knew. "Also, I told everyone we wouldn't bombard their city from orbit."

The formerly wounded clone, sitting in the centre of Darla's lounge, glanced at Adora, then at Priest.

Adora smiled gently at him, and Priest nodded. "Speak, brother, so we know who tried to murder you before you were saved by Her Divine Grace!"

The Clone beamed, nodding eagerly, before blinking. "Uh… we were door-knocking like we had trained."

"And why weren't you with your partner?"

"Ah, that is, we had passed a food stand earlier, and he had gone back to fetch us some 'hot dogs'." The clone cringed a little. "I

thought I could handle a house alone - we'd been to many already."

Priest nodded, taking this breach of regulations better than Catra had expected. Or maybe he thought that Adora healing the clone had wiped away any fault. Catra hadn't delved too deeply into Priest's views.

"So, I ring the doorbell, and this woman appears, and I ask her if she had heard of Her Divine Highness, She-Ra. She had, and so I started explaining, and she was listening, when an older man appeared, yelling at her not to listen to me. And then he started cursing me." The clone raised his chin. "The curses of the ignorant cannot hurt the faithful, so I ignored him. But he started berating the woman, and they started a row, and then he… he insulted Your Divine Highness!" He scowled deeply.

Catra pressed her lips together. She had a hunch of where this was going.

"I told him not to slander Your Divine Highness, but he… he doubled down! I told him that those who slandered She-Ra would not be saved, and he kept cursing me as a heathen and sprouting inane sentences, and… well, I told him he was stupid and his god was wrong, and he yelled something about how his daughter wouldn't be corrupted, and then he suddenly drew a gun and shot me. I don't remember much after that. Everyone was screaming." The clone lowered his head, then glanced at Adora.

Catra sighed as her friends looked at each other. Definitely not good optics.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, October 27th (Earth Time)

Usually, Jack O'Neill didn't like - or outright hated - travelling to Washington D.C. because that meant talking to the brass at the Pentagon about things they didn't really understand. Or to

politicians who didn't understand anything. Usually, it meant preventing some more or less well-meaning (or downright malicious) idiot from sabotaging Stargate Command, wasting time that would be better spent on actually doing his job.

Which, incidentally, was leading SG-1 in the field and waging war, not playing politics. He was a colonel, not a general.

But today, he almost enjoyed his trip to Washington D.C. Sure, he might have to talk to politicians, but this was the President, not Kinsey. And while the occasion was serious - having an alien visitor shot on one's watch was always serious - it got him out of the mountain just when he needed a change of scenery. And some distance between himself and certain very competent and far too attractive female officers of Stargate Command. About whom he definitely didn't have any thoughts that might violate regulations or common sense, respectively. Not at all.

"Say, Jack…"

Daniel turned from watching the streets of Washington, chock-full of cars, to Daniel, who was sitting next to him in the staff car. "Yes?"

"Don't you think Sam should have come with us as well?"

Jack suppressed a sigh.

Daniel went on: "I mean, sure, she's a physicist, not an anthropologist, but she's been working with the Etherians the most, and she probably has the best picture of how they're going to react. And she can just call Entrapta and ask if she doesn't know the answer."

"Carter has urgent work to do," Jack replied. "She said so herself." Even though both Jack and Carter had known it was 'not entirely factual', as she would say. "And she gave us her opinion on the Etherians' reaction." In writing.

“Yes, but…” Daniel must have noticed something about Jack’s mood since he trailed off. He didn’t stop talking, of course. Not Daniel. “Is this about Lenkova?”

Yes. “No,” Jack said, narrowing his eyes.

This time, Daniel got the message. Though the pout he showed when he slowly nodded told Jack that his friend would bring this up again.

Damn. Jack needed to sort out this before then.

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“...and many people have come together in a vigil at the site of the shooting, showing their concern and empathy for the wounded alien. A few protestors were sent away by the police, allegedly for their own protection. In other news, the North Shore University Hospital required police protection as hundreds of people tried to enter it in the hope of getting healed, despite the announcement that Adora had already left the building - and Earth - again. Experts are divided about the effects this incident will have on the relations between the United States and Etheria.”

Jack O’Neill rolled his eyes at the TV screen in the room where he and Daniel were waiting to talk to the cabinet. Technically, the United States government wasn’t negotiating with Etheria but with the Princess Alliance. Effectively, they represented Etheria, of course, but… He blinked - he was thinking like Daniel! Damn!

At least his friend hadn’t noticed - he was looking through news sites on his laptop. And Daniel didn’t seem to be happy.

“What’s wrong?” Jack asked.

“It’s just… how stupid are people? Glimmer repeatedly said the Etherians wouldn’t retaliate - or blame the United States for this - and this so-called expert claims that this was a clear threat! I mean, I expect biases from this news company, but outright insanity?”

Jack craned his neck and checked the article's origin. Ah. "They're pandering to their audience." Which was a bunch of radical nutcases.

"Still… Facts are facts!"

"And that article is an *opinion piece*." Jack grinned at Daniel's expression.

Even better, before Daniel could say anything in return, an aide entered the room and called them to meet the cabinet.

*****

"...and that's I don't think this incident will have a significant negative influence on our relations with the Etherians: They know that this was the action of a lone individual, and they do not blame the United States for it. Further, they are also aware that the proselytising the victim engaged in is somewhat divisive," Daniel finally finished.

"I see," the President said. "That concurs with the opinion of our analysts."

"And Captain Carter's summary," Jack O'Neill added. He earned a few glares from other cabinet members for speaking without being addressed, but the President nodded in agreement.

"That's reassuring. Less reassuring is that this happened in the first place." The President didn't look at anyone in particular, but Jack saw several members of the cabinet tense up.

"We can't really convince everyone that we need the Etherians as allies more than we need 'god's support'," the Secretary of Education said - her tone making it clear what she thought of the idea that there was any question about what the United States needed.

"We've got the media on our side, though," the Secretary of State replied. "With the exception of fringe newspapers and the odd

opinion piece."

"The incident did rile up the more extremist Evangelicals, though - the idea that aliens are allowed to proselytise on United States soil is a very touchy subject," the Secretary of Defense said.

"We know that," the President retorted. "We've all seen the polls. But the constitution, regardless of what some radicals think, is clear about this." He sighed. "Of course, I wish they wouldn't have put us on the spot like this. Things were all on track for the amendment, and now we've got this mess to deal with."

"The Etherians might not have had much of a choice," Daniel pointed out. "They have to deal with religious radicals as well, after all."

The Secretary of Defense frowned. "Can't they just order them to shut up and stop making trouble? They are absolute monarchs! Hell, one of them is worshipped as a god by those aliens!"

Jack smiled as Daniel pushed his glasses up and went into lecture mode. "It's a common misconception that absolute monarchs rule absolutely. The clones are a vital part of the Alliance military, and their desires and opinions carry a lot of weight. Further, I think it's clear that Adora is unwilling to use her position to tell others what religion they should follow - or not follow. So, it should be evident that…"

Jack leaned back a little and tuned his friend out.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, October 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and yes, that's the complete list of locations with magical activity on Earth as far as we know. There might be other such sites that aren't active right now but will become active should certain conditions be met - conditions which we also don't know yet."

Glimmer sounded annoyed. Adora wanted to pat her shoulder when she sat down after answering another stupid question from the assembly, but that would have left the wrong impression. So she nodded at her friend. This was the fifth 'special session' of the United Nations about magic after Adora had restored it, and the questions hadn't really changed. In fact, many of the hostile ambassadors always asked the same questions Adora and her friends couldn't answer, probably just so they could keep claiming that magic was not known well enough and so it would be too dangerous to legalise it.

Another ambassador rose to ask a question. Adora noticed it was the one from Iran, heard the first line about responsibility, and sighed. The same 'question' again. As soon as he had finished, she rose. "No, we will not 'assume responsibility' for any damage done by magic. First, you still have not submitted any proof that the fire and flooding - or the sickness - were caused by magic. Second, magic is a natural force. Restoring it to Earth is not the same as providing everyone with a loaded gun. It's like restoring the laws of physics that make it possible for gunpowder to work." She smiled, even though after four such sessions, she now could quote Entrapa and Bow's arguments in her sleep. And sometimes did, at least according to Catra. "We didn't teach anyone in your country to actually use magic; that's all on them."

"Without your actions, none of this would have happened!"

Adora shrugged. The man wasn't entirely wrong. If they hadn't restored magic to Earth, spells and powers wouldn't work. But magitech would. And as they had found out in Honduras, magitech could be as dangerous as advanced non-magical technology.

Something Glimmer was, as always, quick to point out: "Even if your calamities were caused by magic, it could have been magitech, which was already working before we restored magic."

"And we answered that question already in the last session. And the session before that." Catra openly sneered at the ambassador.

Adora pressed her lips together. They should stop attending those sessions - it made everyone's temper worse.

"At least give us scanners to detect magic!" the ambassador all but yelled. "How are we supposed to protect our people from magic if we can't even find it?"

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "No country that hasn't legalised magic - and given guarantees to prevent witch hunts - will receive magic scanners." She leaned forward and glared at the man. "Do you think we're stupid? You'll use those scanners to hunt down people with the talent to use magic! And then you'd claim they were evil no matter what they actually did!"

"We do not execute people simply for having such a talent!" the ambassador protested. "But criminals are criminals, whether they are magical or not!"

Adora glared. Sure, a number of 'sorceresses' in Iran were sent to prison and not executed, and many more were 'lynched' by 'private citizens', not the police, but so far, none of the murderers had been prosecuted either. Still, it wasn't enough to intervene.

"The scanners aren't ready yet, anyway," Catra added before yawning theatrically. "Does anyone actually have a question that wasn't answered already before this session?"

Adora knew she should scold Catra for the breach of protocol, but she just couldn't bother. Listening to the same questions session after session was simply too repetitive.

Yet another ambassador from the Middle East complained about magic. At least many African countries had stopped that - apparently, many traditional healers suddenly found their medicines and treatments working much more effectively.

"They're just running those sessions so they can funnel people in for you to heal," Catra whispered.

Adora frowned at her. She wasn't about to ignore someone suffering in front of her! It wasn't their fault that they were sick!

"You know I'm right." Catra smirked.

"They should look for sorceresses of their own," Adora said. "That would solve their problems with magic."

"They are looking for their own sorceresses," Catra retorted. "So they can kill them." She leaned back and stretched her arms over her head. "It would be more fun listening to Priest explaining why you're a goddess even though you deny it."

Adora pouted in return. She couldn't just order Priest to stop… worshipping her. No matter how much it annoyed her. She had been the one to defeat Horde Prime and free the clones, after all. It was only natural that some of them would fixate on her as their new leader - they didn't know any better. Adora knew how it was, being raised by the Horde and not knowing the truth. And how difficult it was for many to change, she added to herself with a glance a Catra. She could only hope that the clones would realise that she was no goddess if Adora kept explaining it.

And, a small part inside her mind that sounded like Catra because that was what Catra had told her many times, it was better if the Clones worshipped her instead of worshipping anyone else. Like an enemy of theirs. Or the Goa'uld. Better for the clones and everyone else.

"...and the way you offer your lapdogs training in sorcery but refuse to help countries that don't bow to your demands shows your bias!"

Right, they were at the 'stop helping your allies' part now. They hadn't even finalised the agreement to train some sorceresses on Earth yet! Or recruited instructors from Etheria - they needed a Stargate for that, anyway. And that was a little tricky. Both politically and with regard to security. They might just install it on a moon. And then there was the technology exchange. In theory,

the clones could help with basic instructions, but they would likely use the opportunity to proselytise as well… They had so many more important things to do than listening to people complain about magic!

"We should ask Entrapta to build a bot to answer those questions," Catra commented as yet another ambassador asked about magic schools. "Make them look like us, but the size of Emily!"

Adora giggled at that.

Well, this, too, would pass, as Jack said. And they were making progress. Sooner or later, things would work out.

But they really needed to stop attending those stupid sessions. They had much more important things to do.

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The Recon Mission Part 1

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, November 14th, 1998

"Who the hell had the stupid idea to pick this as the new site of the Stargate? I want to know so we can send them to Thule!"

Samantha Carter didn't react to the Colonel's profanity. In fact, she had an urge to curse herself - the cold and the biting wind here at Canadian Force Base Goose Bay reminded her far too much of the time the Colonel and herself had been stuck in that cave in Antarctica. Even the best cold weather gear they were wearing couldn't keep them completely warm. Maybe she should have worn the spacesuit Entrapta had made for her - the cold wouldn't bother her at all, and the suit was very comfortable to wear. On the other hand, it might cause some resentment from the rest of the Stargate Command delegation visiting the site. And some idiots would claim that as a woman, she was too weak and soft to stand the temperature…

"I thought you liked Canada," Daniel commented, shielding his face with his hand. Or trying to - his glasses were fogging over.

"I like hockey. I don't like moving from Colorado to the arctic. To the butt end of the arctic, to be precise," the Colonel griped. "There was nothing wrong with Colorado."

Sam knew that it had been a mostly political choice. The United Nations didn't want the gate to remain in the USA. And the USA didn't want the gate to move too far away - and still had enough pull to ensure that. Sam thought the Australians had had the best proposal. Woomera or Exmouth would have been perfect from a strategic and logistical perspective. Easy to supply, not much

buildup necessary. And remote enough so one could fight an invasion without endangering too many civilians.

But that had been too far from Europe, and so, between the USA, France and Britain, Canada's proposal had won out. And Stargate Command would have to adjust.

"Probably picked so the Russians would feel at home - it's as cold as in Siberia."

"Really?" Daniel blinked. "Well, when we visited Siberia, it wasn't winter. Were you in Siberia during winter?"

The Colonel scoffed but didn't answer. Which was to be expected.

"The location is rather remote, but it has a port," Sam pointed out. "And the Canadian government is already constructing a railway line to link it up with the Canadian railway network."

"The port will need to be expanded if we want to ship in all the supplies we need quickly enough to get this done in a timely fashion," the Colonel said. "As things are, we need a lot more infrastructure here to supply an invasion through the gate."

"I thought we didn't plan to run invasions through the gate?" Daniel frowned.

"Not for the initial attack. But we might need to use a gate to deliver supplies - we might not have access to spaceships for supplies." The Colonel shrugged. "You never know what happens in a war. Even if you think it'll be a cakewalk. Especially if you think it'll be a cakewalk."

Sam nodded. The Colonel knew that better than everyone else here, given his experiences during the Gulf War.

"Supplying an Earth invasion force, especially a mechanised one, through the gate will be difficult." Teal'c didn't seem to be bothered by the cold. Or just didn't show any reaction. "It would severely restrict the use of the gate for other reasons."

“Well, it’s better than the mountain,” Daniel said. “We can’t exactly ship lots of supplies through the base.”

That was true, of course. The Colonel still grumbled. Then again, he liked playing the grumpy old man from time to time. “One attempted invasion and the Canadians will scream to move it to Australia. And once the public realises that gates work both ways, someone will want to move it to Mars.”

“I think the logistical challenges of moving the Stargate to Mars and operating it there would severely reduce its usefulness.”

“Well, that was a joke, Teal’c.”

“Ah.”

Sam couldn’t tell if Teal’c had actually thought that the Colonel had been serious. Wait, his lips twitched - that was him pulling the Colonel’s leg.

“And, speaking of Mars… Is it true that you suggested surveying a landing site in advance of the Mars mission NASA is launching soon, Sam?” Daniel wanted to know.

“Oh, planning to steal NASA’s thunder?”

Sam rolled her eyes. “I merely suggested using some of the recon bots we’re building to search for the ideal landing site.”

“But that would drive home that this isn’t a brave exploration mission, but just a few scientists taking a cab to Mars.” The Colonel chuckled. “Imagine them arriving, and you and Entrapta are having a picnic there!”

“We’re too busy to have a picnic on Mars, sir.” As if Sam would be so petty as to do that!

“But you’ll keep an eye on the Mars base, right?” Daniel asked. “I mean… I am not trying to disparage NASA’s engineers, but they are building this modular base in a hurry, aren’t they?”

Sam nodded. "The Etherians will keep a frigate in orbit to support and, if necessary, evacuate the scientists."

"And to nuke any hostile Martians from space." The Colonel clapped his hands together. "Anyway, let's blow this joint. We came, we saw the miserable freezing place here, and we can safely say that the best way to use this base is to build a huge bunker so we're at least warm while we're here. And an underground railroad so we won't ever have to go outside."

"Except for field training, right?" Daniel asked in an earnest tone. But he was grinning.

And the Colonel scowled.

*****

Whitehall, Westminster, London, United Kingdom, Earth, November 16th, 1998

"...and since everyone is present, the first strategy meeting of the United Alliance of Earth and Etheria has officially started. The first item to discuss is the location of the Alliance Headquarters. I suggest that it should be located on Earth and reasonably close to the Stargate to make emergency meetings easier to attend."

Glimmer went full steam ahead, as the humans would say, Catra noted. From the opening speech straight down to business. Then again, it had taken months longer than Catra had hoped to get the Alliance going and dealing with all the issues the rest of the world had brought up - well, more like making sure the bigotted idiots wouldn't make trouble for the Alliance - and they really needed to get things sorted out to get the war started. The longer an enemy was left in peace, the harder it would be to defeat them.

And, as expected, the Earth parts of the Alliance all took offence at this.

“But the majority of the Alliance member states are in Europe!” the French representative protested. “We should be picking a central location in Europe.”

“Why not pick Brussels? It’s already the NATO headquarters!” the Belgian representative pointed out. Though, as Catra had noticed, not too many were paying attention to him - or to the delegates from the other small European countries that had joined the Alliance.

“Germany would be happy to host the headquarters, but we think that military concerns should take precedence over political ones.” The German Minister of Defence nodded at his colleagues.

“Political concerns are military concerns during a war,” the French minister shot back. “You cannot separate them.”

“Canada would be honoured to not only host the Stargate but also the Alliance Headquarters.”

“Iceland would also be willing to host the headquarters, We can offer a geographical compromise.”

“You don’t even have a military!” the Danish representative snapped.

That was true. Catra didn’t quite get why Iceland had joined the Alliance. They were supposedly recruiting volunteers, but they lacked any military tradition and the closest they had come to war in centuries was a conflict over fish with an ally of theirs.

But turning a willing ally away would have sent the wrong message, and compared to some kingdoms on Etheria, they weren’t too small. Still, Catra didn’t think they would be much use in the war. They probably would end up joining the forces of the Kingdom of Snows.

“I think Iceland is too remote to serve as headquarters,” the German Minister of Defence commented.

“The United Kingdom is neither remote nor bereft of armed forces. And geographically and culturally, we’re a good compromise - especially with an eye on the eventual joining of the United States.”

Which were still trying to get the amendment to guarantee gay marriage and all the other rights passed. Or ratified - whatever the process was called. Catra had stopped paying close attention to it after the sixth time she had thought they were finally done only to hear that this had been just another step. The Americans must really hate changing anything about their laws, the way they made it so hard and complicated.

“I think the Stargate’s location isn’t of crucial importance. In an emergency, we all would have to take a plane - or one of the shuttles, once they are available - so anyone arriving through the gate could do the same and arrive at the same time.” The minister from Norway had a good point, in Catra’s opinion. Good enough that the rest of the ministers acknowledged it.

Of course, they then used that to explain why the headquarters would be best placed in their country.

“Just pick a country,” Catra snapped when the Swedish delegate proposed a rotating headquarter. “If you don’t want it near the Stargate, then its location doesn’t really matter as long as there aren’t too many civilians around it. You just need a big bunker to house everyone. And defences, of course.”

Adora nodded. “Yes. Although it would be nice if it would serve as a staging ground as well for the Alliance forces, we don’t need to combine both locations. It might be even safer to split them up so a strike at one location doesn’t take out both.”

Of course, that started a discussion about the location of the main base, more political and infrastructure questions, and more bickering over security and accessibility. And some of the concerns… family visiting? And being housed? On a military base?

Catra shook her head. “We never had those problems in the Horde.”

“That’s because we didn’t have families in the Horde.”

“Well, yes, but that’s not the point.” Catra pouted. Really, who wanted to take their family into a base? Coming home would feel like getting back to the barracks! But, apparently, things were different on Earth. The scale of the bases and the number of civilians involved… “Might as well build a new town - or found a new kingdom,” she whispered.

That made Adora giggle, even if it wasn’t funny.

At least Catra knew that the humans wouldn’t take forever to decide this. It was clear, even though none said so, that they wanted everything settled before the Americans could join.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 18th, 1998

“...and with that decision by the General Assembly of Ohio, two-thirds of the states have now ratified the amendment. That means…”

Jack O’Neill switched the TV off.

“I was watching that!” Daniel protested.

“You were watching the same commentary that happened thirty-four times before?” Jack raised his eyebrows as he looked for a good place to lean against, or sit on, in Daniel’s office. There was the second chair, of course, but that would have made him look tired.

Daniel pouted in return. “It’s a historic event. I want to follow it from start to finish. The social repercussions and changes this will cause…”

“It’s a done deal,” Jack cut him off. “Congress voted on it. And the states are ratifying it. The only reason it’s taking as long as it takes is that some states are dragging their feet scheduling the votes.” Mainly because the NID hadn’t taken care of every influential conservative that would rather keep the gay down than let the United States make an alliance with lesbian magical space princesses that would net them advanced technology. At least Jack thought so. They reminded him of some of the ‘Segregation Forever!’-types.

“Well,” Daniel said, “some pundits seem to think that the delay is less due to holdouts but because some states want to be the deciding vote, so to speak.” He shrugged. “I don’t think it’s likely - they would probably be remembered as the last holdout rather than the deciding vote - but it might explain some of the scheduling troubles.”

Jack snorted. He also doubted it. “Sounds more like a desperate attempt to fill the news while everyone is waiting for the amendment to finally take effect.” Especially the armed forces. They needed the alliance as soon as possible. If they waited any longer, the war would start without them, and the United States would be forced to enter it on someone else’s terms. Mainly, the Europeans’ terms.

And, judging by the rumours that Jack had heard from Entrapta about how they bickered over everything, that would be a bad idea. Jack didn’t want to live in England for the war. Or, even worse, Iceland. At least no one had proposed Greenland for the base or headquarters.

“Well…” Daniel shrugged again. “Usually, the truth about such things isn’t known until much later.” He put a stack of papers down. Jack couldn’t read their titles from his spot and didn’t feel like asking his friend about it. Probably something about medieval societies that Daniel then could complain about not being applicable to Etherians or something.

“I just wish we were already in negotiations about the alliance,” Jack muttered.

Daniel frowned. “We can’t join without the amendment being passed.”

“We could hash out the details for the alliance in advance, though. So, as soon as the final state gets around to voting, we can sign the alliance.” It was just a formality, anyway. Well, most of it.

“Catra said it was rather straightforward - they’ve streamlined the process since the start. All the Scandinavian countries joined without lengthy negotiations,” Daniel pointed out.

“That’s what I am afraid of,” Jack replied. Conditions aimed at small countries like Norway or Sweden wouldn’t fit the United States.

His friend frowned again. “Why?”

“Of all the countries, we’re the only one with experience fighting the Goa’uld. Not even the Etherians have any experience. We should be more involved.” Granted, they mostly had experience with small unit actions through the Stargate, and the Alliance was gearing up for a conventional war - in space - but they knew their enemy. Especially Teal’c. Jack wasn’t looking forward to seeing the Alliance repeat Operation Torch.

“Ah.” Daniel nodded, apparently conceding the point. “I don’t think the Etherians will ignore our advice, though.”

“Maybe not.” Jack wasn’t so optimistic.

“So, what’s up?” Daniel suddenly asked. “You didn’t come here to watch CNN with me.”

Jack snorted. “Can’t I come to visit you to chat?”

Daniel blinked. “Sure. But you’re usually a bit too busy at this time of the day.”

"A meeting fell through," Jack explained. And he hadn't felt like doing paperwork.

Daniel nodded. "And Sam's in France with Entratpta, looking at the shuttle factory they are building there."

"Yes." Another fait-accompli, as the French would say. The Europeans weren't wasting any time taking advanced technology. Even though it was mostly automated, according to Carter. Wait! Jack narrowed his eyes at Daniel's expression. Was he insinuating something more?

"Between Stargate Command, the projects with Entrapta and the NASA mission to Mars she's advising, Sam's quite busy. Maybe you should order her to take a break," Daniel went on.

He was. Jack shot him a look. "Carter knows how to take care of herself. I don't need to babysit her." Unlike Daniel.

"It's not about babysitting," Daniel protested, "but relaxing and socialising."

His friend was right - they hadn't had time to relax, hadn't they? "Well, the Christmas parties are coming," Jack pointed out. Even though Alliance talks and meetings would probably hijack those. Hell, the fighting with the Navy was getting downright vicious - ever since the Royal Navy had apparently come out on top in the struggle in Britain, the Navy pukes had been getting cocky.

But Daniel didn't look satisfied. Jack almost wanted to ask if he was trying to play matchmaker but refrained from doing so. Some things you didn't talk about. And Jack's relationship with Carter, not that there was such a thing, fell firmly into that category. He'd rather discuss medieval culture than that. Or soccer.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, November 20th, 1998

“So… France can’t host the headquarters because they already got a shuttle factory and more coming,” Adora summed up the results of the latest meeting. The latest tiresome meeting.

“And because they’re French,” Catra added, stretching on her chair in that distracting way of hers, then slumping down as if she were made of liquid, about to ooze over the edge of her seat.

“No one said that.” Adora scowled at her lover.

“It was implied,” Glimmer cut in. “Apparently, leaving the NATO - or partially leaving - in the past is being held against them, but no one is as rude as to say so to their face.”

But everyone knew it. Or used the argument. Adora sighed. “And Germany won’t get the headquarters because they want to host the main base for the Alliance so it will help ‘revitalise’ their eastern parts.”

“Yes.”

“Even though they could just plant the new factories they want there?” Adora was not an expert on economics, but she had read up on the theory. You put up a factory where no one was, and that caused the area to gain workers and income.

“Those are going to be built in locations with established factory complexes, in the other parts of Germany,” Bow said. “They want to use the trained workforces there.”

“They don’t want to make those people already working there mad for losing out,” Gimmer explained. “The government relies on their support.”

“Ah.” That made somewhat sense.

“And the Germans have the most experience hosting lots of foreign troops, so there shouldn’t be too much friction, at least that’s what they claim.” Catra’s smirk told Adora she didn’t believe them.

“But the British want to host the base as well - and they also claim they have experience, although that was decades ago during their last great war,” Glimmer went on.

“The Second World War,” Bow corrected her.

Glimmer frowned at him for a moment. “Yes. Anyway, they are angling to get more industries in exchange for giving up their claim.”

Catra snorted. “Sounds like a bunch of bandits in the Crimson Waste haggling over who gets what part of the loot!”

Adora pressed her lips together. She couldn’t quite refute that. “So, who’s winning?”

“Whoever we pick,” Glimmer replied. “If we want to pick one. But it’s pretty clear that they won’t pick locations that we wouldn’t like.”

“Do we want to?” Bow asked. “Seems like no matter who we pick, everyone else will be mad at us.”

Catra sat straighter. “We don’t want locations that can’t handle the logistics and defences. And we don’t want locations that have historical issues with others in the Alliance. For headquarters, something that’s easy to defend against spies would be best.”

“For headquarters, we have to pick something with enough infrastructure to cater to all the officers stationed there,” Glimmer corrected her. “They need a certain level of comfort,” she added with a snort.

Catra chuckled. “Sounds like Bright Moon.”

Gimmer narrowed her eyes at her. “Bright Moon’s soldiers can rough it.”

“But you don’t like to rough it.” Catra flashed her teeth in a wide grin. “Even your dungeons look like luxury guest rooms.”

Bow cleared his throat. “So, uh… Do we actually want to pick a location? We don’t care for that, do we?”

“We don’t,” Adora said.

“And letting our allies pick it means we have more leverage when something comes up that we want to decide,” Glimmer agreed. “I think they’ll pick Belgium for headquarters; they already have NATO headquarters there and the seat of the European Union, which means most of their leaders are used to it.”

Adora nodded even though her impression had been that no one was taking Belgium’s proposal seriously. But Glimmer knew more about politics, and it did sound like a good compromise. “And the base?”

Glimmer shrugged. “Beats me. It needs to be somewhat remote so we can have the soldiers exercise there. And we need to build a spaceport. Canada or Australia would offer good locations, as would the USA, but in my impression, most want it to be located in Europe.”

Adora sighed again. Petty politics! There wouldn’t be that much fuss about the location of Etheria’s Stargate, that was certain.

“Well, with the USA close to finally sorting themselves out,” Catra said, “I bet our allies will quickly find a compromise.”

“Just as they found a compromise regarding advanced technology,” Glimmer added with a lot of sarcasm.

“Well, having factories with advanced technology in every country means they’re less vulnerable to attacks and sabotage - you can’t get too much with one attack,” Bow said with a smile.

That was true, but Adora was sure this was more like a side-effect and not the main reason the Europeans wanted to spread out all the military factories they needed built. “Anyway…”

She was interrupted by an alert from Darla. An incoming call from… Stargate Command. Marked urgent.

"Put it on the screen," Adora told the ship.

A moment later, Jack appeared on the big screen in the centre. He nodded at them. "Hello, everyone."

Adora caught Catra sitting up straight - Jack looked grim and serious. That was bad news.

"We've got a situation here. Off-planet."

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 20th, 1998

"...and so the last thing we heard from the team, before contact was lost, was that the planet was under attack."

Samantha Carter looked up as she heard the Colonel's voice and saw him enter the gate control room with the Etherians in tow - well, most of them. Hordak probably stayed on Darla.

"And nothing since?" Adora asked.

"Nothing, though…"

"Hi, Sam!" Entrapta interrupted him and waved at Sam.

"Hi." Sam waved back, then had to suppress a wince - this wasn't a friendly meeting in the privacy of their labs or off-duty. They were in the middle of a crisis.

"So." Catra cocked her head sideways. "Your team went through the gate, which was deserted, and then started exploring. Which means that the gate wasn't guarded by anyone on the planet. And it was still open when the attack happened, so it didn't come through the gate."

“Yes,” the Colonel confirmed.

“We didn’t see any signs that the planet was occupied when we sent a MALP through.” General Haig joined them, looking grim. “And the team didn’t find any signs of recent activities at the gate either.”

Sam nodded. The gate area had been overgrown. If there had been regular traffic, there would have been some trails at least. And if there had been recent traffic, even on foot, there should have been tracks. But according to all the data they had, the gate address belonged to an abandoned planet. That was why it had been thought to be a good choice for the Russian main team’s first real mission.

“So, whatever is on the planet is important enough to merit an attack from space but not important enough to have the gate guarded.” Adora shook her head. “That doesn’t sound good. Do you have any maps of the area?”

“No.” The general shook his head. “It was an exploration mission.”

“No auto-mapper?” Entrapta pouted. “You should have sent a bot along that can automap. They’re very useful!”

And they were something Stargate Command didn’t have. Sam smiled wrily at the general’s expression. The MALPs capabilities were very limited compared to the capabilities of such a bot - she was familiar with either.

”Yep. Such bots would be very useful. I’ll make a note to buy some next time I go shopping,” the Colonel said.

Entrapta blinked. “Oh, you don’t have them? I can build you one!”

“Thanks, but I think we should focus on saving our team first.”

“It could be useful for that, too!” Entrapta nodded. “We can build one while you do your planning, right, Sam?”

It wasn't as if she was doing anything useful right now, Sam knew. This wasn't, at least not yet, a technological or scientific problem to tackle. But she'd like to get in on the planning. Or at least attend. On the other hand, the bot could be very useful for the mission itself. She looked at the Colonel, who nodded back at her.

"Yeah, you do your thing while we plan the rescue mission."

Haig nodded his assent, and so Sam and Entrapta went to Sam's lab.

"So… I'm thinking standard spy bot with integrated automapping and scanner. They're small and cute but very eager! We shouldn't have to modify the basic design much but we can if you want," Entrapta said once they were in the lift, and a holoprojection detailing the small bot appeared next to her.

Sam wanted such a tool herself. Just displaying data in the field would be so useful - scratching a quick sketch on paper, or even in the dirt, just didn't compare. Still… "I don't think we need any modifications. The planet has a standard atmosphere and temperature, at least around the gate. And we need to get it quickly."

"Right! We could have Hordak send one down, but I think we'll be quicker building one from the parts in your lab!" Entrapta beamed. "This is going to be fun!"

Sam noticed the glances the Russian guards - Stargate Command was on alert now - gave them as they stepped out of the lift, but there wasn't anything she could do about it right now. They didn't know that Entrapta wasn't making fun of the situation - she just was a little different. And a good friend.

And she was right - this was going to be fun.

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By the time they entered the gate room, a bot chattering in its own language in tow, the rest of SG-1 and the Etherians were ready to go. Sam was, once again, struck by the contrast. SG-1 was suited up - her own armoured vest, reinforced with advanced technology courtesy of Entrapta, was ready on the table next to the Colonel - while the Etherians hadn't changed at all. Adora hadn't even transformed into She-Ra. They looked as if they were here to supervise, like the generals with them.

And Emily, who was towering over everyone, was carrying what must be their emergency gear like rations and tents. Sam really needed to get a bot of her own.

"So… let's send the little guy through and see what the area looks like!" the Colonel said, clapping his hands.

"Yes." Sidorov glared at all of them. "While you were wasting time, my team might have been killed!"

That was a distinct possibility - losing radio contact was never a good sign. And even though Lenkova was a skilled officer, she had no experience with Goa'uld or aliens, and training could only take you so far. The odds for the Russian team weren't good.

And Sam wasn't entirely sure how she felt about that.

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"So… let's see if the planet is still around and wasn't glassed. Or blown up," Catra said, taking care to roll her neck as if this was just another day at the training facilities. Or the personal exercise room in the palace these days. Instead of a dangerous mission to save a bunch of humans from body-snatching aliens before they got body-snatched. Or just snatched.

In hindsight, it was a pretty bad idea to just let Earth continue their Stargate missions, even though Stargate Command had claimed that they were being very careful. From what she had heard, SG-1 had a lot of experience, but they hadn't been too cautious either when they ran things, and now with the new

committee in charge, things were bound to be worse. Glimmer claimed that the Alliance couldn't dictate policies to the rest of the world, but in Catra's opinion, the needs of the war were more important than playing nice with people who endangered everyone through their actions.

Even if it was a little hypocritical. Maybe more than a little.

But the spy bot was now walking towards the gate ramp, Entrapta and Sam hovering over it. Well, Entrapta was doing the hovering - Sam was mostly checking readings while slipping into her armoured vest.

Which was actually a nice piece of kit. Not the armour - Catra's suit was armoured already while still granting full mobility - but the pouches and pockets and stuff. If you didn't have a magic sword that could change into whatever tool you wanted, you had to make do with normal tools, and while her claws were great, they couldn't do everything. It would make carrying explosives easier as well - sure, she was carrying some of the bombs they had used to blow up Princess Prom, but bigger bombs wouldn't go amiss.

Of course, she couldn't say this, but if she claimed that it was a show of unity or something with their new allies, the others might buy it. Bow might even want to make a vest for himself that left his midriff bare.

"...and be careful, OK? If there's anything dangerous, report at once, and we'll shut down the gate so you can dial back!" Entrapta patted the small bot on its head or sensor dome or whatever you call it.

"I'm not telling her that the bot's not going to come back if there are enemies at the gate," Catra whispered to Adora.

She saw her lover flinch a little before raising her chin. "This is a Stargate Command mission. We shouldn't assume to speak for them."

Catra chuckled at that. Adora could be sneaky sometimes.

As if she had heard them - but she hadn't; Catra was sure - Sam said: "Ah. We can only allow opening a gate to us if there's no chance that an enemy will follow us - the risk that they could invade or just send a bomb through is too great." She looked embarrassed, in Catra's impression. Or ashamed.

The bot beeped. Entrapta frowned at it. "That doesn't matter! You're a member of our team like everyone else!"

"What do you mean?" the Russian idiot butted in. "Are you talking to the robot?"

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "And her name is Beatrice."

"You give your robots names?" The general was blinking.

Catra saw O'Neill stepping closer as Entrapta said: "Of course! They need names so we can talk to them without being rude."

"But they are…" The Russian trailed off. "Are they intelligent?"

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "Or do you mean sapient? Beatrice would need an adaptive matrix that will allow her to learn and grow to become sapient. I wanted to give her one because sapient bots can adapt much better to various environments and situations, which would make her more efficient at exploring new planets, but Sam said that we should stick to normal bots for security."

"Ah." The Russian nodded a bit jerkily. "Do not build sapient bots without permission from the committee," he told Sam.

"Of course not, sir," she replied.

"Good. We do not want robots turning on us."

"And we don't have political commissars to threaten bots with execution to send them on suicide missions," O'Neill added.

The Russian scowled at him. “We haven’t had commissars for a long time now.”

Right. O’Neill had mentioned those or some people like them once, Catra remembered. Dimly.

“Now let’s send the bot through. We need to save our team!” the general ordered.

Everyone stepped clear of the ramp, and even the bot scuttled off it before the gate was dialled.

As soon as the iris was retracted, the bot beeped to Entrapta and Sam once more, then disappeared through the gate.

“She’s so brave!” Entrapta said, wiping her eyes.

The Russian looked a little odd at that, but Catra didn’t care - she was staring at the big screen showing the feed from Beatrice.

The gate area looked untouched - lots of grass, tall enough to force the bot to extend its head so it could still see above it. There wasn’t anyone nearby, but the big plumes of smoke on the horizon weren’t a good sign.

“Running a spectral analysis,” Sam announced.

A few seconds later, Entrapta piped up: “Oh! Looks like… plastic and metal particles in those clouds.”

“Those are artificial structures or vehicles burning, sir,” Sam reported. “And more than a few.”

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Gate Area, PX4-223, November 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“Stay sharp, folks!” Jack O’Neill snapped as he stepped down the stone ramp, carbine ready as he scanned his surroundings. The sky was clear, the front was clear, the flanks and back, clear. He

crouched down at the end of the ramp, next to the D.H.D., and studied the smoke on the horizon. Yeah, he had seen such smoke before. When a column of Iraqi vehicles had been destroyed. He could almost smell the stench of burned plastic - and burned flesh.

Teal'c took the other side of the ramp, his staff held low. And the big robot, Emily, had already thrown up a shield. Just in case the spy bot had missed an ambush. Which Jack had expected - whoever was attacking the planet should be covering the gate if only to keep reinforcements from arriving or their targets from fleeing. Any attack on a planet with a gate always focused on the gate. That was just common sense.

So, why wasn't the gate guarded? A trap? Or was the gate damaged?

Carter was behind Jack. "The D.H.D. doesn't show any signs of damage or tampering, sir," she reported before he could ask.

Jack nodded. The Russians had checked it right after arriving, but you always checked yourself. Nothing worse than getting stuck on a hostile planet thousands of lightyears from home.

Catra landed on all fours right at the end of the ramp - she must have jumped. And she sniffed the grass? Then Melog joined her. "Seems clear. I only smell human. And Melog can't sense anyone near us," Catra announced.

Then She-Ra reached the end of the ramp, her sword drawn, followed by Glimmer and Bow. "No magic," Glimmer said.

Jack nodded. He had also expected that. It made things a little harder for the Etherians - but in a pinch, She-Ra could return magic in a minute. And probably get a big boost. But where were the bad guys? They must be watching the gate from afar - they had spotted Lenkova's team, so they would be aware that the Russians had come through the gate. But they wouldn't be prepared for the Etherians; magic or not, their allies were

veterans. While Jack wouldn't trade SG-1 for them, they knew their business very well.

"Beatrice! Good girl! You performed exactly to specs! I am so proud of you! Who's a good spy bot? You are! Keep your sensors aimed, will you? There might be bad guys around! And Emily, you're doing good as well!"

Jack suppressed a sigh. Well, most of them knew how to behave in a hostile environment. But if Carter started cooing over robots, he'd put his foot down. On the robot.

"The stone is lacking any ornaments. Old, but not as old as the gate. I don't see any sign of whoever would have built the ramp, Jack," Daniel said.

"Yep." Not that Jack had expected any useful information from the ramp - most of the gates had something like it to keep the activation kawoosh from killing people waiting in the area.

"Alright." Jack nodded towards the hills in front of them. "The action is that way. And our missing Russian allies also moved in that direction, as the trail here shows." And, according to the logs, roamed a little too far for a first mission - Lekova must have been cocky. Then again, the hills in front of them would offer the best vantage point for the entire area. Which was why Jack was sure that they'd find the tracks of the Russians leading there.

And the tracks of their captors or killers so they could save or avenge the team.

He looked at his team and the Etherians. "Let's follow the trail."

"Melog will warn us if there's an ambush ahead."

Jack could get used to that cat. And it shouldn't take too long - Lenkova's team had been here for less than an hour when contact had been lost. Even if the Russians had done a forced march, that wouldn't have taken them too far. A couple of miles - probably not

enough to reach the top of the ridge. “And stay sharp!” he repeated himself. “The snakes must be watching us.”

“We’ll spot them if they come to cover the gate.”

“Beatrice will tell us!” Entrapta said. The spy bot skittered away, hiding in the grass.

“And if they get to the gate before us, Adora can restore magic, and I can port us back in seconds,” Glimmer announced.

Jack nodded. Though She-Ra might turn half the planet into a jungle or something in the process. And he couldn’t help being worried. Why weren’t the owners of whatever was burning behind the ridge running to the gate? And why hadn’t they been using the gate?

Well, they would soon find out. One way or the other.

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Chapter End Notes

Thanks to Meshakhad for researching valid locations for the Stargate!

The Recon Mission Part 2

PX4-223, November 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora kept looking around as they entered a light forest. She knew that Catra, who was in front of them, had much better ears, that Melog would sense people nearby, and that Entrapta was scanning for energy signatures or something while riding Emily, but some things were ingrained after years of training.

And covering your sector while on patrol was one of them. She was third in line, so she was watching the sky above as well as the left arc. At least by Horde standards. Americans might have different standards. And Bright Moon didn't have standard patrol training for everyone - their scouting was usually done by tightly-knit local teams who did things their way because they knew the terrain better than anyone else. She made a mental note to cover that point in one of the strategy meetings about the training regime for the Alliance. And she would propose to go with the Horde standard - or what the Earth armies used. The Bright Moon system was defensive in nature and wouldn't be of any use on foreign planets.

Well, Jack was ahead of her and to the right, so he would be covering the right arc. And Teal'c was covering the rear arc. So they should be good.

Catra made a gagging noise ahead of them. "Ew."

"What's up? Allergies?" Jack asked.

"No. I just caught a whiff of smoke," Catra replied. "That's not just plastic and metal burning there. Smells like a Horde transport that brewed up with a squad inside."

Adora winced - she knew what that smelt like because she had blown up a few of them in the war. Also hovertanks.

"Ah." Jack nodded.

“So that was what the carbon molecules were in the smoke.” Entrapta nodded. “I’ll update the data banks for the future. Good to know!”

Adora didn’t have to look at SG-1 to know most of them would be wincing. Well, Sam should know Entrapta didn’t mean anything by it, and Teal’c wouldn’t move a muscle in his face unless he wanted to, but Jack and Daniel were wincing.

“Let’s follow the trail,” Jack said. “And hope it wasn’t our team that was turned into airborne pollution.”

“Jack!” Daniel protested.

“What? It’s scientifically correct, isn’t it?”

“That’s not the point!”

“But it is!” Entrapta chimed in.

Adora sighed and focused on her surroundings as they continued their trek. The tracks left by the Russian team were faint - apparently, they knew how to move without leaving a trail - but between Catra and Melog, with some help from Bow when needed, they could follow them just fine. They weren’t as good as Bright Moon or Plumerian scouts.

After about a quarter of an hour, Catra suddenly stopped again. “I smell blood.”

Everyone tensed. “Proceed carefully,” Jack whispered. “Teal’c, go around on the right. Bow…”

“Taking left.”

The two split off, and Catra continued, more slowly this time. Adora felt as if she were back in the war, sneaking up on Horde troops. She tensed and drew her sword. If anything happened, she would be ready.

Catra stopped again, then went down on all fours and crawled ahead, followed by Melog.

Adora moved ahead, hiding behind a tree, peering around its trunk. She couldn't see much, but… Oh. Those were… not blaster burns. But something similar on the trees ahead.

"It's clear," Catra's voice rang out over the radio.

Adora moved at once, stepping past her lover's position. She was She-Ra - if Catra had missed a threat, Adora could handle it best.

And she was in the middle of a clearing. Next to a body. Two bodies - she could see another under a bush a bit away. Both were wearing ornate armour.

"I saw no enemies on this side," Teal'c said, appearing to her right.

"Clear here as well." Bow joined them, looking grim. "There's another body there." He pointed back. "And it's wearing a Russian uniform."

"This is a Jaffa wearing the standard armour of those who serve the false god Apophis," Teal'c said, kneeling next to the first body.

"But you think it might be a false flag?" Jack asked.

"They left the bodies with their gear. That would be a waste - and disrespectful of the fallen warriors."

"Unless they were in a hurry," Jack pointed out. "Like when you're getting attacked out of the blue."

"Yes. Still… where are the bodies of the others?"

They found another Russian a bit away. He had been hit in the stomach and crawled beneath a bush, where he died. Messily. And two more dead Jaffa.

But there was no sign of the other two missing Russians.

“Are there any tracks of… the Russians?” Jack asked.

“None that lead away,” Bow replied. He pointed at the start of a small trail. “But some of the prints there are much deeper than others.”

“Either they have giants amongst the Jaffa, or they are carrying prisoners,” Jack said, looking grim. “Carter, call Stargate Command and inform them that two members were captured and that we’re in pursuit.”

“Yes, sir!”

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“...and there’s still nothing on the radio. Weird. That smoke is composed of advanced materials - well, the remnants of them - and the byproducts of burning those advanced materials, and some people, too - so why is there no radio traffic? See?”

Samantha Carter took a look at Entrapta’s multipurpose tool. Mostly because her friend was holding it in front of her face. She didn’t doubt the results - she had seen them herself. “Yes. This is strange,” she agreed.

“First the gate left uncovered, now no radio communications…” The Colonel looked grim. “I don’t like that. We’re missing something.” He looked at the hills.

Sam knew what he was thinking. The trail they were following - well, which they would be following as soon as Catra, Melog and Bow managed to find it again after losing it in that stream they had reached - led away from the ridge behind which vehicles or buildings were still burning. If they wanted to know what was going on there, they would either have to abandon the pursuit of the Jaffa who had captured the Russians or split up. Neither was a good idea.

“Maybe they’re using another form of communication?” Daniel speculated.

“Our scanner’s covering every frequency and spectrum we know,” Entrapta retorted. “If they’re using something unknown, then that would mean we’re faced with an entirely new technology!” She beamed. “Can you imagine it?”

“What if they are using magic?” Daniel asked.

“Hm.” Entrapta blinked. “That’s theoretically possible, but it would have to be magitech since Adora still hasn’t activated magic on this planet. And we should be able to detect any power sources powerful enough to power magic.” She blinked again. “That was a lot of power in that sentence.”

Sam chuckled. “Yes. But I think even if the attackers are using magic or an unknown technology to communicate, the Jaffa fighting for Apophis would be using known methods of communication.”

“Unless good old Aphophis found some Ancient technology since we blew up his flagship and distributed it to his goons.” The Colonel’s mood hadn’t improved. On the contrary.

And Sam agreed again - that was a rather daunting possibility. Technology not even the Etherians and the Horde had? She’d rather face a System Lord using magic. On the other hand… who knew what kind of magic knowledge a thousand years old Goa’uld had? They supposedly hadn’t been using magic even before Etheria swallowed it all, but Sam didn’t trust that assessment.

“Well, we’ll find out soon!” Entrapta, of course, was undaunted. “I can’t wait!”

“Yeah, I betcha.”

Sam checked her own scanner - she really needed to upgrade it. Still no signals.

Then Catra returned. “Melog found the trail. They went east in the stream.”

“Back towards the hills?” The Colonel looked sceptical.

Catra shrugged. “I think it’s a detour. But we’ve lost enough time checking both upstream and downstream. Let’s go.”

“Right. We’ve got people to save.”

Or to avenge. If those Jaffa were working for a Goa’uld… Sam suppressed the shiver that remembering her own possession caused. It was a fate worse than death.

They didn’t walk in the stream themselves as they walked - with Emily, there was no way to avoid leaving an obvious trail. Melog and Bow were waiting for them a few hundred yards away. “They went this way,” Bow said, pointing northwest.

“I knew it - a detour!” Catra grinned.

“Or that’s what they want us to think. Those are the worst kind of enemies,” the Colonel said. “Smart ones.”

“We’ll find out soon,” Adora said.

“Well, at least this time, we’re not the ones being outgunned by the snakes,” the Colonel told Sam as they followed a narrow trail. “We’ve got the magic powerhouse and Emily the walking artillery with us.”

He was correct - Sam had to remind herself that appearances were deceiving. They might look like light infantry with a robot, but they had the firepower of a mechanised platoon. At least. And if She-Ra restored magic…

They marched on for almost half an hour. Entrapta was riding on Emily again, and Daniel was looking a little worn by now - he was putting up a good front, and he was in better shape than when he

had joined Stargate Command, but the group was moving at a quick pace.

But then, they stopped, and Catra whispered through the radio: "Got a hidden bunker ahead of us. Melog's sensing people inside."

"Let's find out if we're looking at a fortress or a bolthole," the Colonel muttered as he moved to the front. "With our luck, it's probably a fortress complex big enough to make the Swiss jealous."

Sam hoped he was wrong.

He was, but not by far. As their magical scanner showed, they were facing a decent-sized bunker. Big enough to house a starship - and unless Sam was misreading the power readings, one that was powering up already.

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Outside Goa'uld Underground Base, PX4-223, November 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

A Goa'uld ship, powering up. Inside a fortified hill. There were times when Catra missed the Horde. To be more precise, what she missed was being in command of the Horde. Today was such a time.

"If we had a squadron of hovertanks, we could just blow the entrance open. And they'd draw fire so we'd notice any hidden guns the scan might have missed," she muttered as she studied the hill hiding an enemy facility. Or some artillery to shell the hill.

"I don't think the scan missed anything," Adora whispered next to her. "Especially not the ship."

Which they needed to stop. "Where are the hangar doors?" Catra asked over the radio.

“Lemme check... Hangar doors… Ah, there - straight up! Top of the hill! Well, a little to the west.”

So they would be covered from sight and direct fire from whatever was burning behind the ridge. Made sense. “Well, fancy cutting another ship in half?” She turned her head and grinned at Adora.

Her lover frowned for a moment, then slowly nodded. “We need to stop them.”

“We can try to hack the door controls if we can hack the communication system,” Entrapta cut in.

“If Adora gets up there, she can stop the ship and get us inside,” Catra pointed out.

“Yes.” Catra expected Adora to charge ahead, but her lover was hesitating. “Jack?” she asked.

“Alright, stopping the ship takes priority. Without blowing it up, please, since our people might be on it. Go get the hangar.” O’Neill nodded.

And Adora took off like a rocket, dashing across the small clearing towards the flank of the hill.

With Catra right behind her, of course. As if she’d let her lover do this alone! Even if Adora could do it alone. Though Catra had to drop to all fours to keep up.

Before she could glance back to check what their friends were doing, guns opened up from the hill. Staff cannons or whatever they were called - blasts tore up the ground nearby as Catra began to weave between shots, once jumping over one, baring her teeth as she charged ahead.

Adora just kept going, swatting a blast away with her sword when she got closer. “Stay behind me!”

Catra had the urge to swerve to the side in response to that - she could charge the hill perfectly fine by herself! - but stayed close to and behind her lover. Someone had to ensure she didn't fall for a stupid trick or so.

They reached the foot of the hill and kept going. Adora swatted another blast away, then turned her sword into a shield, catching one, then another shot as she went straight towards a gun emplacement, then past it.

Catra, hot on her heels, grinned as she slashed with her claws and cut the barrel of the gun as she passed it herself. A moment later, the gun exploded, taking the emplacement with it. If the blaster fire or the ship's engines turning on hadn't alarmed whoever was invading the planet, then the smoke would. Well, that couldn't be helped.

They were about to reach the top of the hill, and Catra pushed the button on her radio. "How many guns are on the top of the hill?"

"Uh… Two. West and east," Entrapta replied.

Pretty weak as anti-aircraft artillery went. But Catra wouldn't complain. "Taking East!" she yelled, veering off.

"West!" Adora replied.

By the time they crested the hilltop, the gun emplacements were already firing. The gunners were better than their friends below - the shots came much closer to Catra as she rushed forward.

Closer, but not close enough. Catra jumped, rolled and came up next to the gun. She ripped it in half with her claws, then rolled away. Once again, the gun exploded, and Catra heard someone scream inside the bunker.

Adora had literally crushed the gun emplacement on the other side just in time for the hangar doors starting to pull away, tearing the grass and bushes growing here apart. The hangar hadn't been

used regularly, then - probably a bolthole with an escape ship, Catra realised.

And now it was a trap. As soon as the gap was wide enough, Adora jumped down the hole. Catra was a bit more cautious, crouching at the edge and looking down. There was a small transport down there - a Tel'tak, if she wasn't mistaken. Adora had dropped on top of it right when it had started to hover and drove her sword through the engine section.

The ship fell about a yard down, and Catra gritted her teeth at the crashing sound. But the crew was already charging out of it, staff weapons at the ready.

Catra came down on one of them, feet first. Her claws almost went through him into the floor, breaking her fall, and she rolled off. A swipe with her hands cut deep into the leg of another Jaffa firing on Adora, and the man fell to the ground. Her claws tore through his throat before he could recover.

That was it for the hangar, but… there was still someone inside the ship. Catra could hear them. More than one. And footsteps from the side door - reinforcements were arriving.

She grinned, flashing her fangs. After months of politics on Earth, she could finally cut loose!

"Check the ship!" she snapped, then dashed forward, pouncing on the first Jaffa who came through the door, her claws ripping through both his arms and his weapon. As he started to scream, blood gushing from the stumps, she was already inside the reach of the next, kicking the staff weapon to the side as she gutted the man and cut the larva inside his belly at the same time.

The last of the reinforcements got a shot off so close, she felt the heat on her cheek before she swept his legs, but a miss was a miss. She knocked him out with a straight blow to the head. They needed prisoners, after all.

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Jack O'Neill ducked as he ran towards the now revealed bunker entrance. Emily's shield might be covering them, and the huge bot certainly had drawn fire right until the last gun covering their approach had been *melted* by an arrow from Bow - and Jack wasn't sure he wanted to know how that had worked - but he knew better than to think everything was going according to plan. Some defenders might make a sally - the Jaffa were crazy like that.

They reached the now revealed doors, and Carter went straight for their controls. By the time Entrapta joined her, she already had the covering plate off.

"Adora and Catra have reached the top of the hill," Glimmer said. "We've got them trapped now."

Jack made a vaguely agreeing noise. The snakes were tricky - you couldn't assume that they were done for until you had them in the morgue or a secure cell. Even though things were looking good thanks to the Etherians. SG-1 would have found a way into the hill without their help, Jack was sure of that, but they wouldn't have been able to just charge it and shrug off whatever the Jaffa threw at them.

Glancing at Emily, he made a mental note to ask Carter to make a bot with a shield generator for SG-1. They needed it.

"Oh, look at that architecture!"

Jack turned, carbine rising, but the door was still locked - Entrapta was gushing over the computer innards or something. Or she was talking about the architecture inside - she was looking at her multi-tool-thingy.

"How much longer, Carter?" Jack asked.

"I can't yet… Done!"

Jack grinned as the door started to open, taking a step to the side. A blast from a staff weapon splashed against the shield, and

the Jaffa in the door died before he could fire another one, hit by Jack's burst and a volley from Teal'c.

Unfortunately, the entrance was a bit too narrow for Emily, so things would be trickier now. Assaulting an underground complex was never really safe. Unless you were a magical space princess who could shrug off tank rounds, maybe. But Adora was busy stopping a ship from taking off. Probably by grabbing its tail and just holding onto it.

So Jack took the lead, Teal'c behind him, backed by Bow. Glimmer could watch Carter and Entrapta, which would keep Her Majesty from the frontline as a neat side-effect. And Emily could guard the exit.

He stepped over the dead body, then rushed forward, pressing his back against the wall at the first corner. A glance - and he ducked back in time to avoid the staff blast sent at him. The wall on the other side exploded in a small cloud of smoke and fire. But Jack had already grabbed a grenade. Pulling the pin and throwing it was almost an instinct.

"Fire in the hole!"

He was around the corner as soon as the explosion went off, charging ahead. Another body was on the ground, where the shooter had been, and Jack put a burst into it without thinking, already looking for more enemies.

But he didn't see anyone, and no one was firing at him, either. "See any bad guys on your scanner?" he snapped as the others caught up.

"Uh… no… yes, but they're all going into the hangar," Entrapta reported. "Three… two… one… none."

What? Oh. "All down?"

"Yes."

Melog the creepy space cat made a noise that was probably agreement.

“The rest of the complex is clear, sir,” Carter told him. “Except for the Tel’tak. Scans are impeded there, though.”

“So, if our people are alive, they’re in the ship.” Jack nodded.

“Unless they are in a room shielded from our scanners.”

Of course. Not that it was likely - if the snakes could do that, they would have hidden the entire facility - Jack knew a bolthole if he saw one. “Let’s go join the others!”

It didn’t take them long to reach the hangar, and not even Daniel was distracted by the luxury quarters they passed on the way - Goa’uld simply didn’t do spartan.

The ship looked… well, it wasn’t burning, but there were still sparks flying around the remains of its engines. Adora and Catra were staring at the ship’s doors.

Jack cursed. If those two hadn’t yet taken down the snakes or Jaffa inside the ship, then that left one obvious conclusion. “Hostages?”

Catra nodded with a grim expression. Well, they were veterans.

“Let’s negotiate,” Jack said with a sneer. “But if you can take a shot, do it,” he added in a whisper.

The others nodded, and Jack took a step forward. His people, his responsibility. “Hey! We’ve got you pinned down. How about you surrender, and we won’t kill you?”

Daniel muttered something behind him, but Jack ignored him. The snakes were too arrogant to appreciate a more respectful tone anyway.

To his mild surprise, the door slowly opened, and he saw a figure stepping onto the ramp - no, two. Lenkova, beaten up but alive, in the grip of a Jaffa who held a zat to her head. She was conscious as well, one hand on the arm around her neck, the other dangling at her side.

She hadn't gone down easily, then. Good. Jack hadn't expected anything else.

The Jaffa said something in gibberish.

"He wants a ship in exchange for the hostages," Daniel translated. "Or a passage through the gate."

Teal'c said something in return. The way the Jaffa sneered at him, it could have been either an insult to the guy's parents or something about not following false gods.

Another Jaffa appeared, holding up the axe-wielding Russian. The guy looked worse than Lenkova - he was unconscious and had badly-dressed wounds.

Another comment in gibberish.

"They say that he will kill the man if we need proof that they are serious," Daniel translated.

Damn. Jack clenched his teeth. He hated negotiating with hostage takers.

*****

Adora clenched her teeth and glared at the Jaffa holding Lieutenant Lenkova. She hated hostage situations. For all her power, she couldn't do anything without risking an innocent. She was *probably* quick enough to take out the Jaffa before he could kill his hostage, but she couldn't be sure - it would take only a twitch of his finger to fire the weapon. And that would still leave the second hostage. Adora couldn't get both at the same time.

And coordinating with her allies and friends… still too dangerous. The slightest delay would doom one hostage.

"Tell them that if they kill a hostage, we'll kill them all," Jack said. He was so angry, Adora could almost feel the tension.

Daniel translated. Entrapta mumbled something about working on a translation matrix in the future. And Catra…

…had cocked her head and was glancing at Melog. "Are you sure? Dumb question, sorry."

Oh! Adora understood. If Melog could create an illusion to fool the Jaffa, Adora and her friends could easily stop them. But Melog needed magic for that. And Adora hadn't restored magic to the planet yet. Stupid - she should have done that right after arriving. Then Glimmer would be able to teleport, Melog could do magic, and… well, it would be enough.

But they could still do it. Pretend to give in to the Jaffa's demand, retreat as a sign of goodwill, restore magic, then strike. Yes, that was a good plan.

"Adora." Catra's hiss interrupted her planning. "Get the one on the right. Now!"

The one holding the wounded man. For a moment, Adora hesitated. This would endanger Lieutenant Lenkova. But it was Catra. She would have a plan.

Adora rushed forward, covering the distance in an instant, her sword flashing. The blade cut through the Jaffa's arm before he could fire his weapon, and he stumbled back, blood gushing from his stump as his hand, still holding the weapon, dropped to the ground.

Adora whirled to face the other…

…and saw him aim his weapon at Catra, throwing his hostage to the side. Catra ducked under the blast, dropping to all fours, then

pounced - past the Jaffa, claws ripping through his neck before she landed on Lieutenant Lenkova, knocking the woman out…

What? Adora gasped. Why would…?

"She's a Goa'uld," Catra snapped. "Melog sensed the snake."

Oh, no! Adora drew a sharp breath.

Jack cursed.

"Yes," Entrapta confirmed, looking at her multitool. "There's a parasite wrapped around her spine."

"But… the Jaffa couldn't use their larvae. So, where's the body of the original host?" Daniel asked. "Wouldn't you have seen it on the scanner?"

"Blocked inside the ship. Or disintegrated," Jack said. "Damn." He had his gun trained on the unconscious woman, Adora realised. And he was still so tense…

"Don't shoot her!" she blurted out.

"I wasn't going to," Jack spat. But he wanted to; Adora could tell. "Even if it would be a mercy." Well, everyone could tell.

"Don't worry! We'll figure out how to remove the parasite without killing her!" Entrapta was the only one smiling amongst the group.

But now Daniel was smiling tentatively as well. "Are you sure?"

"If it's possible, we can do it! And there's no reason it should be impossible!" Entrapta beamed. "Sam was once possessed as well, and she's not dead, so possession can end without killing the host. We just have to find out how to do it without the help of the parasite."

"Best keep her sedated, though, to avoid the Goa'uld committing suicide out of spite," Sam said. She was kneeling at the man's

side. “He needs medical help.”

Or healing. Adora bit her lower lip. “I can restore magic and heal him.”

“And half the planet?” Jack asked. “Or resurrect the Jaffa?”

“Jack!” Daniel protested.

“Hey! We don’t know what this planet’s magic will do, do we? It could be zombie apocalypse time.”

Adora frowned - the odds for that were… well, very low. She had never heard of such a thing until she had met SG-1.

“Could the, uh, magic boost you get when you restore it be used to remove a Goa’uld?” Daniel asked.

That was possible. Probably. But Adora couldn’t be sure. And if she healed the woman and the Goa’uld by mistake…

“Let’s not try it in the field. Just get both back through the gate so they can be… treated,” Jack said. “We can experiment when we’re not on a planet under attack.”

Adora nodded.

“What about the attackers?” Catra asked. “We still don’t know what happened here. We should at least take a look.”

“We can do that afterwards. We need to take care of our wounded first,” Jack said. “And of the prisoner.”

He was right. Adora nodded. “Let’s carry them back.”

“Emily can use her transport configuration!” Entrapta said.

“We should secure all data in this ship and bunker, though,” Sam cut in.

“Well, that…”

A beeping sound from Entrapta's tool interrupted them. "Oh! Beatrice says someone's approaching the gate!"

Adora saw Jack check his watch before using his radio. "Stargate Command? SG-1. Close the gate, then redial it. We need to block someone from escaping."

Oh! That was smart - the gate couldn't be kept open forever, just a bit less than an hour, but if they redialed it right now, Adora and her friends would have enough time to get back to the gate while it was still blocked.

"I could teleport us back there in a few seconds," Glimmer offered.

Jack tilted his head. "But we would have to restore magic for that. And risk a zombie apocalypse."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "It would allow us to catch whoever is approaching the gate."

"And find out what is going on here," Catra added.

"And risk Lenkova's life?" Jack retorted.

He was right. Adora could just use the magic for something else, but that was a bit dangerous as well. The last time she had 'improvised', she had turned a huge ship into a plant.

"Let's walk," Adora said.

"And have 'Beatrice' track the guy," Jack added.

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Gate Area, PX4-223, November 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter checked her scanner when they approached the Stargate. "The contact hasn't moved," she reported.

"Still hiding out in the bushes?" the Colonel asked. "Watching us?"

"Yes, sir." Well, she couldn't tell if they were watching the Stargate, but it was very likely. Why else would they hide with a line of sight to the gate area?

"Probably ready to snipe us as soon as we leave Emily's shield," Catra added, staring at the smaller ridge covered with tall grass and bushes.

"The Naquadah detected would fit a weapon like a zat'nik'tel," Entrapta confirmed.

But the range was very far for a zat. Not impossible to hit your target with proper sights, but it came close. And the Goa'uld weapons usually didn't have sights worthy of the name. In addition, the odds of the shot's charge holding together over this distance… "I think they're just observing," Sam said.

Catra scoffed. "Probably waiting until we've left so they can flee through the gate."

That was, again, very likely.

"Well, we need to move our wounded through the gate," the Colonel said as they reached the D.H.D. "Keep an eye on them." Then he tapped his radio. "SG-1 to Stargate Command. We've secured the gate - send the medics through."

A moment later, a mixed team of medics and guards stepped through the gate, followed by Janet.

"Doc?" The Colonel frowned. "It's not that urgent."

"I've got orders to check for biological contamination," Janet replied, already kneeling next to the wounded Russian.

The Colonel muttered something about paranoid Russians but didn't voice any further complaint.

Sam was forced to agree with the precaution. She-Ra might be able to heal anything, and they had the gate area back home

quarantined until scans were done, but it didn't hurt to be a little more cautious here. Even if Entrapta and Sam hadn't detected anything with their scanner.

Janet quickly and efficiently treated the man's wounds before giving the go-ahead for transport. Two medics picked up the stretcher as the gate collapsed, and Sam dialled home.

Janet was already examining Lenkova - far more cautiously than before. Sam approved; if the Goa'uld woke up and couldn't escape, it would try to gain another host. And Janet would be closest.

Sam shivered at the thought, trying not to remember her own possession. Being controlled by an alien, reduced to watching helplessly as her body moved on its own… It was a mercy that Lenkova was unconscious now - no one should suffer through that. Sam would rather die than experience it again, no matter how optimistic Entrapta was about removing the parasite.

But Janet didn't find anything either, nor on the second prisoner, and soon, the secured and sedated Lenkova and the Jaffa Catra had knocked out were carried through the gate as well - escorted by two full teams of guards. The two bodies they had recovered on the way back followed.

And that left SG1 and the Etherians free to deal with their spy.

"Watch the gate," the Colonel ordered the remaining guards. "We're going to flush out our little snake."

"If I could teleport, we could just grab them," Glimmer suggested. "I could drop Adora on them."

"Let's not use the magic whammy just yet," the Colonel objected. "Save that for a surprise."

"If they run, I won't be chasing them all over the planet," Catra said. "Not without a skiff or something."

Which wouldn't fit through the gate or could even reach the gate room. But other vehicles might - small ones like dirt bikes or quads. Once they relocated the Stargate, though, they would have a much easier time getting vehicles to and through the gate.

"Well, let's see if we can fool our little snake. We'll march towards the eastern ridge to watch what's burning, and once in the woods, we'll turn right to come at them from behind." The Colonel grinned. "Should be fun."

"Or we could just wait for them to come to us, Jack," Daniel said.

"Well, I don't think…" The Colonel trailed off and cursed.

Sam looked up and clenched her teeth - the Goa'uld had stopped hiding and was now out in the open, walking towards the gate.

She heard the Colonel mutter a curse under his breath.

"Are they surrendering?" Adora asked.

"They might prefer being captured to being left behind," Bow speculated. "But they could just leave after us."

"It's probably a trick." Catra scoffed. She squinted. "They're armed with a zat."

"Anything else? Like some bombs? Poison?" the Colonel asked.

Sam quickly ran a scan with Entrpata. "No, sir. But it's definitely a Goa'uld host."

"I don't like this."

Sam didn't like it either. It was never a good sign when the Goa'uld deviated from standard behaviour.

Once the Goa'uld was about twenty yards away - fifteen from the outer edge of Emily's force field - the Colonel called out. "That's far enough."

The Goa'uld stopped and nodded. "You're the Tau'ri."

"And you're the Goa'uld," the Colonel shot back. He didn't nod.

"I'm not Goa'uld. I'm Tok'ra."

Sam gasped before she could control herself. Tok'ra. Like Jolinar, who had taken over Sam's body and then ended up sacrificing herself for her.

She closed her eyes for a moment, struggling with the memories. This complicated things.

*****

"I am Jakar of the Tok'ra."

A Tok'ra? Catra narrowed her eyes at the Goa'uld. She had heard of the Tok'ra in a few briefings, and from Sam, but it seemed a little too convenient to meet a Tok'ra here, in the middle of an attack or whatever, when they were blocking the gate and with it, the Goa'uld's escape.

O'Neill seemed to share her thoughts. "Well, that's what a Goa'uld would say, isn't it?" His smile was all teeth.

The Goa'uld wasn't fazed, though. "Only if they would ever think of trying to pass as one of us - and if they would also think they have enough knowledge to manage that. Which is rather unlikely given our secrecy. And how would they know whether or not you have an easy way to verify any such claim?" His smile was friendly. Maybe a little too friendly for Catra's taste.

"Well, it would certainly be nice if we did have an easy way to check your claim." O'Neill shrugged. "But you know… we kind of don't. The last guy of yours we had contact with didn't leave a home address."

"We survive thanks to secrecy," the Goa'uld retorted. "Telling anyone about us would put our agents at risk. If the Goa'uld ever

found our bases, they would destroy us."

"Not telling anyone about you also puts you at risk," Glimmer pointed out. "We can't really check if a Goa'uld is a Tok'ra when we fight them."

"Yes," Adora agreed. "If you're fighting the Goa'uld, you should ally with us."

"And who are you?" the Goa'uld asked. He nodded at Catra. "You are not of the Tau'ri."

Catra grinned in return. "Secrecy saves lives," she said before her friends could blurt out critical information. They already had one Goa'uld who knew everything the Russian woman knew - which included information about the Alliance. "You still haven't proven your identity."

The Goa'uld closed his eyes for a moment, then suddenly spoke with a different voice. "I am Mats, the partner of Jakar. I can vouch for him."

"A Goa'uld would never grant their host control," Daniel said.

"Unless they're desperate," Catra told him. "Or have a way to enforce obedience, like hostages. Or they're just faking it, and it's still the Goa'uld in control."

"Indeed," Teal'c spoke up. "A false god is not forced to use their command voice."

The man tilted his head as he looked at them. "Then it seems that we are at an impasse."

"You could, you know, leave your host so we can be sure you're not controlling him," O'Neill suggested.

"Even if I had the means available here in the field, that wouldn't eliminate the possibility that I am controlled through other means," the man - or the Goa'uld - said.

O’Neill frowned at Catra as if that was her fault. She had just pointed out a weakness in the Goa’ul’s claim!

“I can give you the information to contact one of our agents,” the Goa’uld went on. “They can prove my claims, and I can stay your prisoner until then.”

“You really want to leave the planet, huh?” O’Neill narrowed his eyes.

“Apophis will not take the destruction of one of his secret research facilities without striking back,” Jakar replied. “I don’t know if I managed to prevent an alert from reaching his forces. I sabotaged the normal channels, but if they had a backup channel…” He spread his hands. “I would rather not be present when his ships arrive - or when he sends troops through the gate. He will assume this is an attack of a rival and stop at nothing to find out who would dare strike at him.”

“Research facility?” Entrapta perked up. “What kind of research?”

“Weapons of mass destruction,” Jakar replied. “We couldn’t allow that.”

“Oh.”

It was a good answer. Maybe a little too good for Catra’s taste. The Goa’uld was a little too smooth - he reminded her of Double Trouble. And that wasn’t a good thing. “So, you blew up the entire facility? With everyone inside?”

“Except for the second in command, who managed to escape - but who, I believe, was captured by you. After taking a new host.”

Right, the Goa’uld had watched them send the wounded through the gate.

“Well, if you want to surrender so we can sort out your credentials later, I’m not going to object,” O’Neill said.

And so the Goa'uld could gather more information, of course. Either as a bonus or as the main objective. No, Catra quickly discarded that idea - it would be too dangerous and too unlikely to succeed.

Jakar carefully drew the zat, then put it down on the ground. "I surrender then."

"Good. Now, you don't mind us checking out your claims here, do you?" O'Neill grinned. "I'd like to take your word for it, but I have to check myself what exactly is burning on the other side of that ridge."

"I would suggest you do not linger - Apophis might arrive any moment. He doesn't like his people using the gate here, to keep the location a secret, but in an emergency, he will not hesitate to send troops through the gate."

Catra didn't quite understand how not using the gate kept it secret - was there some registry that got updated every time a gate was used? She would have to ask the others.

But first, they had to verify the claims from the Goa'uld. And then they had to decide how to deal with the Tok'ra.

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The Recon Mission Part 3

PX4-223, November 20th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Alright, careful now - we don't want to run into an ambush." Jack O'Neill knew the odds of running into an ambush were very low - between Catra taking point and Carter and Entrapta scanning - probably mapping the entire planet by now - he didn't think there would be any enemy able to ambush them. Then again, overconfidence was a recipe for disaster.

"We're almost at the ridge," Glimmer pointed out. Jack heard the 'and we could have been here half an hour ago if magic had been restored' without her having to say it - she had said it often enough.

But he didn't trust strange magic. Adora meant well - she was one of the most idealistic persons he knew, even putting Daniel to shame - but Jack really didn't want to risk her getting pumped full of magic and improvising something to use all that power. Not on a strange planet where the Goa'uld were - or had been - researching weapons of mass destruction. The supposed Tok'ra hadn't mentioned what kind of weapons Apophis's goons had been working on, but Jack would bet a month's worth of jello that it was biological weapons. The Goa'uld already had nukes and possibly Naquadah-enhanced nukes, and chemical weapons were more situational and needed more resources to be deployed than biological weapons - and research into chemical weapons wasn't that dangerous. Even if there was an accident, a lab wouldn't have enough of the stuff to threaten more than the lab itself and maybe the area around it.

Biological weapons, though… Those were so dangerous that moving the lab to a forgotten planet and forbidding the researchers and the Jaffa from using the gate for any transport made sense. Of course, moving the lab to a world without a gate might have been even safer, or into a ship, but… Well, who knew what snakes were thinking? Apophis probably wanted to have the

opportunity to reinforce the planet on the quick with expendable troops.

Well, it did backfire on him. If 'Jakar' had told them the truth, of course. They would find out soon.

Catra, ahead of them, dropped to all four and was now crawling up the last part of the hill before the top. Jack bit his tongue before he made a comment about watching her tail - Adora was a very nice girl, and Jack trusted her to watch his back any day, but from what he had learned in their time together from throw-away comments and the odd discussion, Adora's relationship with Catra was something best left alone.

"Yeah, those are burning craters," Catra reported. "Whatever it was, was underground, I'd say."

Jack heard Carter behind him make that little sound that told him she wanted to check herself but was too polite to say so out loud and grinned. A moment later, he reached the ridge's top and pulled out his binocs. Yeah, those looked like bunkers that had blown up. He saw three craters, one of them formed by at least two explosions. But had they blown up from within due to sabotage, or had they been hit by bunker-busters or similar weapons from above?

Well, Carter and Entrapta would find out soon. Jack didn't look at Carter's back when she crawled up the ridge next to him, followed by… Entrapta's hair, which dragged the princess up.

"Oh, the structural damage… yes…"

"The blast pattern is rather distinctive, right, Sam?"

"Yes. And the spread of the broken walls and roofs…"

"Yes! I don't see any trace in any part of an initial penetration, but that could have been wiped by the explosion."

That probably meant that the snake had told them the truth about sabotage being the cause of the explosion. But that didn't mean that the snake had told them the truth about anything else. Jack was almost glad that the gate room was currently under the command of Sidorov - a paranoid Russian officer would ensure that the snake couldn't get free and wreak havoc. Especially since Carter and Entrapta had taken away all the snake's toys.

Jack cleared his throat. "And is there anything biological showing on your thingies?" If the ashes of people were detectable in the smoke, what about biological agents?

"Nothing, sir. I would have informed you at once," Carter replied. She sounded just a tiny bit annoyed at the implication that she might have forgotten to check for traces of bioweapons.

"Emily's keeping an eye out!" Entrapta said. "Nothing on her scanners so far. Of course, an advanced experimental bioweapon might be masquerading as something harmless and only change into a dangerous compound when triggered. At least, that is what I would do should I research something like it."

Jack glanced around - he wasn't the only one wincing at the princess's words. Not by far.

"I don't think we should be researching bioweapons," Adora said with a very forced smile.

"But how can we defend against Goa'uld bioweapons if we don't do any research?"

Jack clenched his teeth. That was an excellent question. He would have to tell Carter to press for a lab in space at once. One with a nuclear self-destruct.

"Looks like there are no survivors," Catra commented after a moment. "I wonder if they were experimenting on people."

Once more, everyone winced. And Jack made a mental note to ask a few pointed questions to their new prisoners - all of them -

about that.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 20th, 1998

"A research facility for biological weapons? And you went there?"

The Russian general looked like he was about to need some healing any moment now, Adora thought. He was red in the face and trembling. Although judging by the way Jack reacted to this sight - or not reacted, as was the case - this was normal for the man. On the other hand, this was Jack. Adora glanced at the rest of SG-1. None of them seemed concerned. Sam was glancing towards where Entrapta and Emily were standing, probably counting the seconds until they could go to her lab. Teal'c was doing his stoic thing and not showing any reaction - then again, that was normal for him. But Daniel also looked unconcerned - at least for the Russian.

Who, Adora noted, didn't seem to care overly much about the dead and wounded members of his team, including Lieutenant Lenkova's possession. Then again, biological weapons were terrifying if you couldn't heal everything with magic. But she could, and the general knew it, so this made not much sense.

"Yes, General," Jack replied. "After careful analysis of the atmosphere and finding no traces of any biological agent. Except for the ashes of the dead."

Adora winced. There had to be a lot of people in the facility for that to be noticeable. Not a few researchers and a handful of guards as she had imagined.

"We're dealing with alien technology here!" Sidorov shook his head. "Alien weapons created to fool alien sensors! You cannot trust such an analysis!"

Ah, that must have rankled Sam. She stood just a bit straighter. “We performed all possible scans, General. Including magical scans. There was no unidentified biological agent in the area or air that we were exposed to - all the organisms we found were familiar.”

“Yes!” Entrapta chimed in. “We took lots of samples! I was hoping for interesting new data, but we didn’t encounter anything we didn’t already know - the planet was probably seeded with bioforms from Earth, although to determine when that happened, we need to extensively analyse the samples we took for genetic drift. Once we know that, we can calculate the time of divergence.”

“I don’t care about that!” the Russian spat. “I care about the danger you might have exposed Earth to with your decision to not only investigate a weapon research facility but take prisoners from there! We had to lock down the entire base to contain a possible outbreak!”

Oh. Adora blinked. “You quarantined the base?” she asked.

“You mean you want to lock us up here?” Catra hissed.

“It’s necessary to ensure that we were not contaminated!” the Russian retorted.

“Quarantine after a potential exposure is standard procedure,” Sam admitted. “But only until the medical officer in charge clears us.”

Well, that was only sensible. “We can wait until then,” Adora said. “I can also heal everyone who was exposed, just in case.” She could do that now that they were back on Earth.

“Or we can have Glimmer teleport us directly onto our sealed shuttle and wait in orbit until you sort out your stuff here,” Catra suggested with a frown at Adora. As if Adora hadn’t a perfectly sensible reason for offering to heal everyone!

“Yes!” Glimmer nodded. “That way, we won’t endanger anyone.”

The Russian general opened his mouth, then closed it again - apparently, he was at a loss for words. Or he had remembered that he wasn’t talking to subordinates.

“Yeah, that sounds like a good idea to keep you from getting stuck here,” Jack agreed. “I think I’ll spend quarantine asking our new guest a few questions.”

Adora frowned at him - it was as if he didn’t want her to heal anyone either!

“I shall join you, O’Neill.”

“I have work to do,” Daniel said.

“We can take you with us,” Entrapta told Sam. “This is a good opportunity to work on getting our space lab going! Bow, you coming as well?”

“Well…”

“I think we should ask the prisoners some questions as well,” Glimmer said.

“Yes,” Catra agreed.

“And I would like to heal Sergeant Popov,” Adora added. At least no one objected to that!

“Granted,” the General told her - after a second or two, though. “But the prisoners are off-limits until we’re sure they aren’t dangerous!”

“That could take a while,” Jack commented with an overly innocent expression. “After all, one of them confessed to blowing up an underground facility as a saboteur and spy.”

"And you brought him here!" the General retorted. "Despite the danger!" He shook his head.

Jack muttered something under his breath that she didn't catch, but Catra giggled. Adora would have to ask her lover after this.

"I think under the circumstances, there's no reason to isolate SG-1 and our allies from the prisoners. The whole base is already locked down, after all." General Haig had arrived. At just the right moment to solve the issue.

Adora couldn't help remembering the officer's course about timing. But she could discuss that later with the others - she had a wounded soldier to heal. And then some prisoners to interrogate.

Especially about the number of people in that base and what they had been doing there before they were killed. Jack had mentioned 'test subjects', and if the saboteur had killed innocent victims of the Goa'uld…

She shook her head as she followed the others to the infirmary. She had to focus on healing the wounded first.

*****

"Say tight! I'm fetching the others!" Glimmer disappeared in a sparkly cloud before Samantha Carter could reply.

That wasn't a bad thing, though. Being teleported wasn't a new experience for Sam. Far from it. Between the ring transporters and whatever the Asgard had used, she had done it often enough. Being teleported by a living being, however, using pure magic… It was a little unnerving. Computers were not perfect, but as long as they worked, they generally did exactly what they were programmed for. And they had perfect memory. Sam was trusting computers with her life every time she used a plane, for example. People, on the other hand, weren't perfect. And they didn't have perfect memory.

Glimmer teleporting her meant that Sam had to trust the princess to transport her solely with the power of her mind and magic. And that took some work, even though Sam would never say so.

But they had arrived safely in the shuttle on the base's landing pad. At least as far as Sam could tell. And it was nice to leave the base despite the mandatory quarantine. Sam didn't have the Colonel's personal history with the Russians in the Cold War, but she had been trained by people with said experience at the Academy, and her experience with Sidorov hadn't been very positive so far.

"OK! The shuttle's sensors show that the seal wasn't breached - we're still isolated from the atmosphere," Entrapta reported.

"And the scans are still negative," Sam added after a check of her instruments.

"Of course!" Entrapta wasn't fazed by the possibility of contamination by biological agents. Not at all - Sam could tell. The princess sat down in her favourite seat on the shuttle. "So, should we have a mandatory quarantine protocol in our spacelab as well? Once we research biological weapons?"

Sam suppressed a sigh. "That would be prudent, yes. But I don't know if we should focus on that area of research." And not merely because Sam was a physicist and not a biologist.

"Why not?"

"I think magitech should take priority. By combining magic and technology, we can gain a clear advantage over the Goa'uld," Sam replied. "Like with our scanner."

"Right. But bioweapons present an obvious danger, especially with the Stargates allowing contaminated people to travel instantly to other planets," Entrapta objected. "If the Goa'uld manage to develop agents that masquerade as - or are - harmless organisms or substances before triggered into taking effect, that could circumvent our sensors."

That was merely a theoretical possibility so far. Sam wouldn't dismiss the possibility, but it would require very detailed knowledge of all the sensors, scanners and other tools the targets used to screen for bioweapons in order to bypass them. Then again, with magic, it might be possible. "The more we improve our magitech scanner, the smaller the chances of the Goa'uld managing to fool them," she said.

"Right! If we can detect it, we can beat it! Adora can heal any sickness, anyway." Entrapta nodded.

"Any sickness we know," Sam said. "There might be something She-Ra's magic cannot handle."

Entrapta blinked, then wrinkled her nose. "In theory, yes. But it would require similar powers, I think - her magic isn't quite like the normal princess type. It's not as limited if she has enough power, though I haven't yet found out if it's actually conceptual magic. We can't easily test for that. Glimmer says it's unlikely since conceptual magic was merely theorised by Mystacore's sages. Although the reasoning is rather weak. She-Ra's healing is not guided by her knowledge - she's no medical expert - but that doesn't mean it's conceptual healing. It's far more likely that her magic just restores the 'healthy' state of the target, which could be easily deduced by magic."

Sam hoped that that was the case. What Entrapta had told her about conceptual magic was… frightening. Magic working from basic concepts - it was almost an outside context problem for reality. Of course, the actual effects might not be very dissimilar. Whether you were healed because magic changed reality according to the concept of healing or because it simply restored your health was likely working out the same for the target.

"So… did you look over the blueprints I sent you?"

"For the lab? Yes." Of course, Sam had looked them over! A lab in space offered so many possibilities! Microgravity, safe conditions for more dangerous research, remote access… And, of course, it

being an Etherian project - nominally - less to no supervision by superiors who lacked the scientific education and knowledge to understand her work. Also, no struggle for a working budget.

There wouldn't be any experiments cancelled because of funding being diverted to other projects or hypothetical dangers of catastrophic failure there. "I think it's a sound layout, though I have a few suggestions, like…"

Glimmer returned with Bow and Adora, interrupting Sam. "Sorry for the delay. Adora had to heal the entire infirmary."

"I couldn't just leave them suffering there!" Adora pouted. "Ah, right! Almost forgot!" A moment later, Sam was staring at the tip of She-Ra's sword.

And then she was healed.

"Just in case there was something on that planet - better safe than sorry, right?"

Sam managed to nod while she blinked and took a deep breath.

"OK, I'm taking Adora back so she and Catra can help interrogate the prisoners," Glimmer announced, but Sam was only half-listening. "Then we can take off!"

She felt… Well, that was what the Colonel must have been feeling ever since he had been healed. She felt… perfect. Perfectly rested, not even a trace of pain or strain.

Wow.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 20th, 1998

"...and you can simply drop off my message and a contact location at this address, and the Tok'ra will make contact. It might

take a while, though - obviously, we do not have a regular schedule for such drops."

The damn Goa'uld is too smug, Catra thought. Far too smug. He acted like he was in charge of them and not inside a cell, leaning back with a wide smile - she was sure that that was the parasite, not the host. But he couldn't actually be that confident, could he? The Tok'ra didn't have too much intel on Earth and nothing on the Alliance. It had to be a front.

And two could play that game.

"Yep, so you say. Of course, letting you write a message is kind of tricky, you know - you might slip in critical intel," O'Neill said.

"Of course I would add critical intel, Colonel O'Neill - I have to prove to my superiors that both my identity and that this isn't a trap but a way to contact a potential ally." Jakar inclined his head. His attitude wasn't as bad as Shadow Weaver's had been, even when she had been in a cell, but still quite condescending.

"You think we could be valuable allies?" O'Neill leaned forward, both hands on the table between them and the Goa'uld.

"I do. While various System Lords remain in ignorance of what you have achieved, we have better information than them. Few powers can boast of fending off an attack personally led by Apophis, although he clearly underestimated you." He nodded at Catra and Adora. "Of course, we didn't know either that you already made allies with another power."

That was a blatant attempt at fishing for information.

"I couldn't possibly comment," O'Neill retorted.

Catra would have preferred a double bluff. An attempt to play up the Alliance so the Tok'ra - if they were the Tok'ra - would think they were just some individuals, or deserters like Teal'c, trying to appear more important. That was how such spies thought. But Stargate Command had insisted on no commenting on Etheria.

"You don't have to. You lost a scout team to the remnants of Apophis's researchers, then rescued the survivors and took out the researchers before they could flee. That is a remarkable achievement."

And they also wrecked the Goa'uld's ship in the process, which probably didn't please Stargate Command. Not that Catra cared - the planet had been too far to fly the ship back to Earth anyway. Well, mostly because Earth didn't have any trained pilots they could spare for the months-long journey without crippling other missions.

O'Neill shrugged. "All in a day's work."

"It was a nice diversion from paperwork," Catra added.

"Of course, you also stumbled onto a secret bioweapon research facility by accident," Jakar went on as if that was a huge revelation and not something anyone would have deduced from their first meeting.

"And speaking of said research facility…" O'Neill smiled, showing all his teeth. "We've got a good idea about its size and structures, but how many people were inside when you blew it up?"

The Goa'uld slowly nodded, and his smile faded. "About a dozen Goa'uld and two dozen Jaffa. They were amongst the top researchers of Apophis and their best assistants. Capturing them was no option, and letting them finish their work was and remains unacceptable. As one of the primary targets of any bioweapon Apophis might develop, I am sure you agree."

"And how many 'test subjects' were in that lab?" O'Neill sounded almost bored, but that was a front, Catra could tell.

And she didn't need to look at Adora to know how tense her lover was.

Apparently, the spy also realised that. "Too many, but they were doomed from the start. At least dying in an explosion is far more

merciful than dying while your lungs slowly decay over days."

"I, we could heal that," Adora blurted out.

Jakar studied her for a moment. "Regrettably, I wasn't aware of your presence until after the deed was done. And I couldn't risk spreading the weapon they were developing by evacuating the prisoners. Entire worlds would have been at risk."

"You could have evacuated them to a deserted planet and then moved supplies to sustain them there. It would have served as an effective quarantine," Adora countered.

"I fear you overestimate the means at my disposal," Jakar told her. "Placing hidden bombs at crucial locations is something I could do, albeit at great risk. However, organising a mass breakout and evacuation at the same time? And timing it so the researchers and their guards wouldn't realise what was going on before it was too late to escape the lab themselves? I doubt there is anyone who could have done this."

And that was more fishing for information. Catra squeezed Adora's thigh before she could tell them how the Alliance would do it. Without Double Trouble.

"So they were collateral damage, huh?" O'Neill asked.

The snake nodded. "A quite apt turn of phrase, Colonel. I regret their loss, but my priorities were clear."

"Yep." O'Neill slowly nodded.

And Catra couldn't tell if he actually agreed, even if he didn't like it. She knew Adora didn't agree, of course. But if Catra had been in Jakar's place, faced with some hellish bioweapon being developed… She wasn't sure if she would have tried to blow up the researchers and most guards in their sleep while saving the test subjects, risking failure and Apophis releasing the weapon later, or would have played it safe and blown up the entire facility with everyone inside.

Even though she knew what would have been the right course of action.

"Well, write your note and give us the address," O'Neill said. "We'll pass it upstairs, and they will decide whether or not we'll risk passing it on."

And the snake was all smiles again. "Thank you, Colonel."

*****

"So, your recommendation is that we should contact the Tok'ra."

Jack O'Neill nodded at General Haig's comment. "Yes, sir." He didn't like the snake they had currently in a cell - they reminded him of a particularly smooth spook he had known years ago, and he didn't really need to remember what that man had done 'in the line of duty' - but they needed to know more about the Tok'ra. The danger of those snakes messing up the war against the other snakes, intentionally or not, was too great to ignore. "If only to check if they're telling us the truth."

The General nodded. "Although this seems to affect far more than merely Stargate Command's operations."

Of course it did. And everyone knew it.

"It primarily involves Stargate Command," Sidorov, as expected objected. "And through it, the United Nations. It was our mission that triggered this."

Jack smiled thinly. It was obvious that the Russian hoped to use the Tok'ra to get advanced technology. Maybe that meant that the Russians weren't as far along in legalising gay marriages as Jack had expected. Daniel might be correct in his view of the influence of the Orthodox Church on politics. And the influence of the supposedly loyal folks left in charge in Chechenya.

"I concur," Li agreed, to no one's surprise. "This contact with a foreign and possibly amiable power should be handled by the

United Nations."

Now, why China hadn't already legalised gay marriage, Jack had no clue. Daniel thought it wasn't about gay rights and more about a power play in the communist party, but that was pure speculation. None of the usual suspects on the talk show circuit had any idea either. Jack hoped the experts working for the government were better informed. But the Chinese would love to have two sides to play off against each other, Jack was sure of that.

And speaking of two sides… He glanced at Adora.

As if on cue, she cleared her throat. "The Princess Alliance was involved in the mission as well, and it's obvious that the Tok'ra are an important factor in the war against the Goa'uld. So, this isn't just or even primarily a Stargate Command affair. But we need to discuss it with the Alliance Command before any steps can be taken."

Haig, Petit and Hammond nodded. "Of course. It seems tabling further steps should wait until our respective governments have discussed this," Haig said.

Jack blinked for a moment until he remembered that British English got it wrong. "So, should we still contact the Tok'ra?"

"Yes. We need to know if Jakar is a Tok'ra or a Goa'uld spy," Adora said, nodding.

Jack watched the generals exchanging glances. If the Tok'ra heard about Jakar being in Earth's custody, making the snake disappear would be more difficult. He doubted that that was why Adora had said it, but Catra hadn't missed the implications - or the generals' reactions. He could see how her ears twitched.

"Yes. We need more information. If the subject in question is trying to deceive us, the whole political aspect would be rendered moot," Haig said.

"But if he isn't, this is an opportunity to make allies amongst the Goa'uld," Adora retorted. "Goa'uld who turned against the Goa'uld Empire;" she added with a smile.

Jack suppressed a cynical smile of his own. Of course, Adora would see this as a way to get more Goa'uld to change sides. But what had worked with the Horde - probably; in Jack's opinion, the jury was still out for Hordak and his 'brothers' - wouldn't work for the snakes. Though Jack would still like to know what exactly made the Tok'ra defect.

Not that it mattered right now. "I'll arrange a mission once the message has been cleared, sir." Which might take a while, of course - the snake had insisted that they had to write in their language, and the resident spooks had a devil of a time trying to find any hidden information in it.

"Yes, Colonel." Haig nodded. "Is there anything else to discuss?"

"Not right now," Catra said.

"I need to look at Lieutenant Lenkova," Adora said. "She's still hurt."

Jack wasn't the only one who tensed.

"She's also possessed by a Goa'uld," Hammond pointed out. "We don't know what effect healing her with magic might have." The unspoken 'and we don't want to find out right now' was clearly understood by everyone in the room - they were still under lockdown, after all.

Adora pouted, but Catra grabbed her hand. "She's not about to die. And we should have Entrapta take a look at her as well before we do anything."

Adora nodded, although very reluctantly.

The girl really needed some perspective. And a lot of rest and recreation, in Jack's opinion. "So, if that's all…?" He grinned - it

was against protocol for him to speak out like that, being the lowest-ranked in the room, but with the Etherians around, he figured he would get away with it.

"Dismissed, Colonel," Hammond told him with a frown.

Jack saluted and left the room.

A moment later, Adora and Catra followed him.

"We'll let Glimmer handle the politics once the quarantine is lifted," Adora told him. "Let's go check up on Lieutenant Lenkova and the prisoners."

Jack nodded. Lenkova was one of his soldiers. As her commander, he had to check on her anyway. "Let's go."

He could set things in motion for the contact mission afterwards.

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Lieutenant Lenkova looked terrible. Adora couldn't help wincing at the sight. Bruises all over her face and arms - the rest of the body was covered with some ugly gown and an only slightly less ugly blanket - tubes stuck in her arms and on her face…

"I thought the parasite would help with her healing," Adora said.

"She's healing faster than normal," the doctor - Janet - explained. "Just not as fast as would be normal for such a possession. Our data is very limited, though, for lack of samples."

'Samples' sounded as bad as 'test subjects', in Adora's opinion. Although she didn't have a better word.

"Could the Goa'uld have suppressed this healing effect?" Catra asked. "So we wouldn't spot it and realise she was possessed?"

"We don't know if they can do that," Janet replied.

“To my knowledge, the false gods cannot do that,” Teal’c, who was apparently standing guard in the infirmary, cut in. “The effects on the host are beyond their control.”

“So, what, this is some weak snake?” Jack raised his eyebrows. “Some defective bloodline or something?”

Janet narrowed her eyes at him. “We can’t tell at this point. We don’t have comparable data.”

Jack grinned at that. “Yeah. We tend to shoot the bastards dead when we encounter them.” He blinked. “And I guess beating up our other guest as a control group isn’t allowed?”

Catra chuckled at the joke. Adora pressed her lips together and didn’t laugh. Even if it was funny in a dark humour kind of way. Teal’c didn’t move a muscle in his face, and Janet glared at Jack even more. “It’s not a joke, Colonel!” she spat.

“Sorry. Just trying to lighten the mood.” Jack looked solemn again. And angry.

“We’ll do what we can for her,” Janet told him.

“We’ll have Entrapta look her over as soon as the quarantine is over and we can focus on that,” Adora offered. And once Entrapta was done, Adora could heal the Lieutenant. Or try to, she added with a silent sigh. Healing magic might not do a thing about the parasite. “But we might have to ask Mystacore for help; they might know about spells that remove parasites of that nature.”

“I thought you didn’t have experience with such possessions,” Janet said.

“We don’t.” The Horde hadn’t had to deal with that, or they would have received some training in how to avoid it - like they got training in how to avoid catching and spreading diseases. “But there might have been similar parasites in the past or in other areas of Etheria,” Adora told her.

“Speaking of contacting Etheria. How’s that going?” Jack asked.

“We’ve sent a small flotilla back with the news when we made the first Alliance,” Adora said. “But they need time to reach it. The next step is to set up a Stargate.” And without a D.H.D., that required a computer and power source on the same level. Which was on Entrapta’s to-do list. Glimmer was still hoping to get a D.H.D. from another source - or the one from Earth, but Adora wasn’t very optimistic about that. At least the computer data from Stargate Command would help a lot, though they hadn’t made a deal for that. Even then, a setup like in Stargate Command would require quite the staff on Etheria. Probably Entrapta or Bow to set it up and run it while training up a crew.

“Ah.” Jack grinned. “It’s like the age of sail again. When news took weeks and months to spread.”

“We’ve mapped out the route now, so speed should improve,” Catra said. “And Entrapta mentioned a plan for using scouting bots to set up a relay chain. Either way, it’ll still be ready long before the Alliance on Earth is ready for war.”

Jack nodded. “Yeah, mobilising a planet for war takes time.”

“Like adjusting your laws,” Catra commented.

Jack shrugged, but it looked a little forced. “That’s not always a bad thing. Rushing something isn’t always a good idea.”

And sometimes, hesitation killed you and your troops. But this wasn’t the time to argue about that. And it wasn’t as if Adora and her friends hadn’t taken things a bit more slowly after they had learned the truth about Earth.

“Aren’t you concerned about the lack of news from your home?” Janet asked.

“We trust our friends,” Adora replied at once.

"Unless they start a new war, things will be fine enough," Catra added. "Between Scorpia and Perfuma, and I guess Netossa and Spinerella, things should be OK. As long as Mermista keeps Seahawk from setting things on fire."

Unless something like the Heart of Etheria was discovered. She-Ra was Etheria's protector. If something happened while she wasn't there… Adora felt Catra's tail wrap around her leg and relaxed a little. Things would be fine. She had to trust their friends.

"So, what's the timeline on the quarantine, Doc?" Jack asked.

"I already gave my medical recommendation hours ago," Janet replied with a scowl. "It's up to the command council to act on it."

Jack shrugged. "They're covering their asses. Nobody wants to be known as the guy who let a deadly alien plague escape containment."

"I hope that they would be more concerned about releasing such a plague than their reputation," Adora said.

Everyone else snorted at that.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 22nd, 1998

It had taken Stargate Command forty-eight hours to lift the quarantine. Samantha Carter couldn't help feeling that it was a compromise solution - or the result of politics. It wasn't long enough to catch most actual diseases - and bioweapons would have, on average, a longer incubation time to spread more easily before anyone noticed an infection and took countermeasures. But it was long enough to show that something had been done, in case something went wrong and people were looking for a scapegoat.

Of course, if there was an actual containment break involving a bioweapon, having ordered a quarantine for forty-eight hours wouldn't save anyone's career - people would be out for blood. But in that case, careers were secondary to lives, anyway. Or should be. Sam wasn't quite sure if everyone in the new Stargate Command shared this sentiment.

"So… do you think we can get a ring transporter for our spacelab?" Entrapta asked, interrupting Sam's thoughts as they walked past Stargate Command's sentries. British soldiers, this time, which still looked weird in the mountain.

"Even if one were available, I doubt it," Sam replied as they entered the lift. "Especially if there is any dangerous research being done in the lab."

"I thought we weren't doing bioweapon research yet." Entrapta cocked her head, her hair compensating while holding various tools.

"Bots, especially bots that can build other bots, are also considered dangerous by my superiors," Sam told her. "Nanotechnology as well." Some of the Luddites even thought Stargates should be isolated - not because of the threat of invasion or infiltration through it, or an attack, but because they feared a spontaneous black hole generation or whatever.

Sam suppressed a sigh at the thought - it was the hysteria about the Large Hadron Collider all over again!

"Oh. Your superiors consider a lot of nifty technology dangerous," Entrapta commented. "That's probably why they are afraid of magic as well."

"Some technology or magic is dangerous," Sam retorted. "But they might be a bit overly cautious," she amended. Although the proposed plans to set up a base on another, deserted planet as a buffer for Earth made some sense. With the secrecy lifted, construction shouldn't be a problem - at least it wouldn't once the

Stargate was relocated; moving any heavy equipment into the mountain and then through the gate was still an exercise in frustration and often futility. The base had never been designed for anything other than small exploration teams - the lack of easy access had been deemed a feature for security reasons.

"Definitely! But that's why we will have remote controls installed! So we can work even when we're not in the lab. Like when we're flying towards it!" Entrapta beamed. "I've already designed the cutest avatars for us!"

Sam nodded with a smile. Which she lost as soon as they arrived in Stargate command and stepped into the hallway. They were here to examine the prisoners, after all. And their victims.

Like Lenkova. The woman was most likely a spy for Russia and a potential threat to SG-1's commanding officer, but no one deserved to become a host for a Goa'uld.

Sam shivered before she could stop herself as they approached the infirmary. She nodded at the guards outside, then at Teal'c inside before greeting Janet with a smile that was only slightly forced. She could do this. She had to do this.

"You don't have to do this," Janet told her in a low voice. "You're not a medical doctor."

But she was, at least as far as she knew, Earth's foremost expert on magitech. "I have to," she replied. No matter how she hated it.

"So, who do we check first? The Tok'ra or the Goa'uld? Well, technically, both are Goa'uld. So, the Tok'ra or the follower of Apophis?" Entrapta, as expected, was genuinely enthusiastic.

"Let's check Lenkova first," Sam said. It would be better to examine Lenkova without any potential bias from talking to Jakar.

"Alright!" Entrapta moved towards the cells, her hair already picking up more tools from the small porter bot trailing after her.

Sam took a deep breath, ignored Janet's concerned look and followed her friend.

Lenkova looked… as expected. Only light bruises. No visible wounds. And so different compared to Sam's image of the woman. Instead of being an attractive, too attractive, confident woman, she looked frail, tied to the bed, with various tubes and sensors attached to her.

"We've been keeping her sedated. So far, the Goa'uld seems to have been sedated as well," Janet explained. "But I wouldn't advise doing that indefinitely. Even if it might be better for her mental health, the long-term effects on someone in her position are unknown. If the Goa'uld should die, she'd die as well."

Sam was aware of that - she had studied everything they knew about Goa'uld possession after… Jolinar.

She forced the memories away. "Let's hope we'll find a solution so we won't have to wake her up before removing the Goa'uld."

"Yes!" Entrapta agreed. "Now let's see what we can find out with our improved scanner mark two!"

Sam nodded and started to help set it up. And if the mark two didn't reveal anything useful, there was the mark four - they hadn't exactly spent the last two days idle, after all. And the mark three's failure hadn't cost them too much time…

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The Experiment Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 22nd, 1998

"...and after yesterday, the amendment only needs to be ratified by one more state. Which, unless the scheduled session of its legislature changes again, will be Pennsylvania. Right, Bob?"

"Yes, Joe! Pennsylvania has gambled by delaying their session until next week and it seems they have won. The eyes of the world - no, the galaxy, since your alien friends will be watching as well - will be on Harrisburg next week when they start their special session."

"I hear CNN is selling advertising slots as if it were the Superbowl, Bob!"

"Hah! You might think you're joking, but I am sure many businesses want to be associated with this historic moment - and I bet that this will have a bigger audience than the moon landings!"

"And speaking of moon landings: NASA has finished their Mars habitat! As soon as they finalise their negotiations with the Etherians, mankind will travel to Mars to stay there!"

"Well, good for them, though I think NASA would have preferred to do so under their own power instead of hitching a ride with an alien cabby."

"Oh, come on, Bob! Who wouldn't want to hitch a ride from magical space princesses? Have you seen them?"

"I have Joe, I have!"

Catra rolled her eyes before raising her voice. "Can someone switch to a channel not populated by horny old guys?" She knew which princess they were lusting after.

The soldier closest to the TV in the mess hall jumped up and quickly started pushing buttons, switching channels rapidly until some animal documentation came up.

"Catra!" Adora hissed. "We're guests here!"

"So?" Catra scoffed. "That doesn't mean we have to listen to some idiots drooling after you."

Adora blinked. "After me?"

"Who else do you think they mean when they're talking about beautiful magical space princesses?" Catra shook her head.

"Uh… Glimmer?"

"She's a queen," Catra pointed out.

"I don't think they care about the exact titles," Adora retorted.

"You're the 'blonde amazon bombshell'," Catra told her. "Glimmer's… not." She didn't need Daniel to realise what was the most common beauty standard on Earth - you just had to watch their television shows and movies.

"I am sure she has fans as well," Adora said with a pout.

"Not nearly as many as you have." Catra was tempted to add 'and you're worshipped as a goddess', but that was a sore spot for Adora.

"That doesn't matter."

"Sure does." Catra grinned. "You're more popular than she is."

Now Adora rolled her eyes. "It's not a competition." Then she blinked and slowly started to grin. "Besides… you might be more popular than Glimmer too!"

Catra growled. "I'm not counting that crowd." She regretted looking up those people. And the kind of pictures they drew. She

suppressed a shudder at the memory.

Adora grinned as if she had won the argument.

Time to change the subject. “So, when are you going to see if you can heal a snake out of a person?”

“Once we got permission from Stargate Command and Entrapta and Sam have all their scanners set up to monitor the situation,” her lover replied.

And they were ready to step in if something went wrong, Catra mentally added.

“But we want to talk to Jakar first - we know they know a way to take a Goa’uld out of a host without the host dying,” Adora went on. “Hopefully, without the Goa’uld dying.”

Catra scoffed. She didn’t care about the lives of people who enslaved others.

“If the Goa’uld knows they’re going to die if we capture them, they will suicide and not let themselves get captured,” Adora pointed out with a frown.

That was true. Catra nodded, acknowledging the point. “We need more sorceresses and healers. And Techmasters,” she said. “Entrapta can’t do everything.” And it would be kind of embarrassing if Etheria ended up not mobilising enough people for the war after berating the Americans for the same mistake.

“I know,” Adora said. “For that, we need the establish a Stargate.”

And for that, they needed a DHD or a computer that could replace it. And for the latter, they needed access to Stargate Command’s computers for Entrapta. Well, that would be a point in the upcoming negotiations with the United States.

Catra leaned back, stretching her arms over her head and throwing her head back. She heard some curses behind her, a

yelp and the clattering noise that told her a tray had been dropped on the ground. "Do they have their own Kyle?" she asked as she turned around and saw a guy sprawled on the floor and covered in food.

"Kyle didn't get distracted by you stretching," Adora told her with a grin.

Catra blinked, then narrowed her eyes. "I see." Was that one of the weird ones? Or one of the people who didn't think having fur and a tail meant you were an animal instead of a person? Earth people had strange views, after all, but some were decent.

Adora was still smiling.

Time to change the subject again. "So, have you heard anything about the mission to contact the Tok'ra?"

"No. They dropped off the message, but nothing came of it so far."

"Ah." Well, Jakar had told them it might take some time. Which made sense. Of course, that was also what a Goa'uld spy would claim to buy time.

They'd find out either way.

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Washington D.C., United States of America, November 25th, 1998

"Did the brass ever hear of 'don't count your chickens before they're hatched'?" Jack O'Neill asked as he leaned back in his seat in the meeting room in the White House that was now far too familiar for his taste. "Pennsylvania's still debating the ratification."

"Every analysis I have watched on television or read in the newspaper agrees that the ratification is a mere formality, O'Neill. And I believe you told me that a sign of competent military leadership is making and updating plans for every possible

situation, no matter how improbable." Teal'c tilted his head slightly towards him.

"Yeeessss, I did," Jack said.

"Then would not this meeting to discuss and advise your leader for the expected negotiations with the Etherian Alliance be an example of such leadership?"

Jack narrowed his eyes. Was Teal'c making fun of him?

Daniel looked up from his laptop. "Jack's aware of that. He's just complaining out of habit, Teal'c."

"Ah. Like the rituals warriors often undergo before important battles."

"Yes, exactly," Daniel grinned.

Jack glared at him, and then at Teal'c for good measure. He would have glared at Carter, but she hadn't stopped typing on her laptop and was acting as if she hadn't heard them. "If we're talking about examples of good leadership, then asking the experts on Etherians a few days before the negotiations begin isn't a good example," he said.

Daniel blinked. "That's actually a good point, Jack. They should have called us for advice earlier. Well, we did brief them regularly, but lately, not as often as we used to…"

"That's because they think we might be too close to the Etherians," Jack told him. If this was the Cold War, and SG-1 wasn't the damn best team in Stargate Command, they would have been sent to some less critical post long ago.

"What? They think we've been compromised?" Daniel gaped.

"I do not think any would dare to question your honour," Teal'c said. "Your history speaks for yourself."

Which was the problem, of course. “Yep,” Jack said. “They know we’ll do the right thing.”

Daniel blinked again. “Oh. You mean… even if the right thing is against orders.”

Like when Apophis had attacked. Jack nodded. The brass hated soldiers who disobeyed orders - even or especially if they got results. Of course, that was why the Etherians trusted SG-1. Something the brass and the government were aware of as well. Imagining how much Kinsey must hate this was a good way to lift Jack’s spirits. The man was a snake - well, figuratively.

“Well…” Daniel seemed at a loss of words for a moment. “We’re all on the same side, though.”

“Like the Western Allies and the Soviets?” Jack told him.

“But… you don’t really think that we’ll end up fighting Etheria after the Goa’uld?” Daniel shook his head.

“Fighting them? No. But once the Goa’uld are gone, a lot of problems and differences won’t look so minor any more,” Jack said.

“Breaking the Alliance would be a very shortsighted view,” Teal’c said. “There are other powers in the galaxy, and it is always better to stand with those who have fought at your side than betray them and your honour for promises of new allies that might turn out to be empty.”

“No one ever accused our leaders of being too concerned with the long-term consequences of their actions,” Jack said. Some of the politicians would be looking to get back at the Etherians for forcing them to change America no matter whether or not the change was for America’s own good.

Daniel snorted at that but didn’t look happy or amused. “Well, as you said, we shouldn’t count our chickens before they’ve hatched.”

"Nope, but we should keep our eyes open for future problems," Jack said. A lot could happen during a war, but as recent events had shown, gratitude was short-lived while resentment lingered.

"And what do we do if our friends ask us for advice?" Daniel asked.

"We won't betray our country, of course," Jack said. "But neither will we betray our friends."

He just hoped he'd never have to choose between the United States and his friends.

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"...so, no, I don't think the Etherians will be too happy if we try to play political games during the negotiations," Jack said. "And they will see through such games," he added. "They're young, but they aren't inexperienced." They already had told the President and the cabinet not to underestimate the Etherians because of their young age, on multiple occasions, but it shouldn't hurt to restate it. Glimmer was a reigning queen who had led her country and an Alliance of other monarchs through a war to the knife against an alien invasion.

"They didn't seem to care when the Europeans played those games," the Secretary of Defence pointed out. "It was NATO all over again, horse-trading and squabbling left and right, so every little country got something."

And case in point. "Glimmer's got experience handling an alliance of different countries as the leader of one of their strongest members," Jack said. "The thing about that horse-trading is, that was back when they were still hashing out where to set up bases. But they've done that. I don't think they would stand for us trying to redo everything at this point." America was the Johnny-come-lately, after all.

"That won't make Congress happy. And the public will expect us to take a leading role in the Alliance." The Secretary of State

shook his head.

"As long as we get the technology and the factories set up, people won't care much." The Secretary of the Treasury made a dismissive noise.

"We can't appear cap in hand, though. We need some concessions," the President said. "Something to show we're not just dancing to the others' tunes."

Jack suppressed a sigh. You didn't sigh at the President.

"It's the optics. The right-wing conservatives are still claiming we've 'sold out the heart and soul of America' to 'Godless aliens'," the Secretary of the Interior complained.

"And they took a beating at the midterms," the Secretary of Education retorted. "The entire party took a beating."

"That was because of special circumstances," the Secretary of the Interior told her with a glance at Kinsey. "But we won't beat them next election if they can campaign on the United States being the junior partner in this Alliance."

"We *are* the junior partner in the Alliance," the Secretary of Defense cut in. "Not forever, if we get the technology trades we want, but, militarily, we're going to play second fiddle to the Etherians for years. And the Europeans have stolen a march on us."

"It's not about the aliens, but the rest of the world," the President spoke up. "The American public won't expect us to take command of the alien space fleets, but they're used to being in charge of NATO. The conservatives, except for the lunatics, won't try to actually annoy the Etherians, but you can bet that they will be campaigning with all the bluster they can muster about 'perfidious Albion' and 'cheese-eating surrender monkeys' lording it over America."

Jack had to suppress a snort at the President's choice of words - they were quite unexpected - but he had to agree that this was likely.

"Bigots ignorant of history aside," the Secretary of Education said, "what are the chances that trying to score points in American politics will backfire on us with our international and interstellar allies?"

"Bet you've been waiting to use that word for weeks," Jack heard the Secretary of Defense mutter under his breath.

But the question was aimed at SG-1. Jack cleared his throat. "I am not an expert on other countries," he said, "but the Etherians generally have a lower tolerance for such games than we do." Catra had the shortest fuse, but Glimmer had a temper as well, and she was their lead in such negotiations. And Adora… well, as nice as she was, she was too idealistic to tolerate much bullshit.

"Yes, ma'am," Daniel added. "They have just fought a war for their world's survival, and they are, as far as I can tell, treating this war against the Goa'uld the same. They will expect and tolerate a certain amount of, ah, scoring points - as ruling monarch, Queen Glimmer will be used to that from Etheria's politics - but anything that directly hampers the war effort will not be received well."

"If the American public loses faith in the Alliance and we lose the White House next election, being replaced with a conservative pandering to the religious vote, that will hinder the war effort as well," the Vice President remarked. "They won't play nice with our allies."

Jack bit down on commenting that it would hamper the man's obvious plan to succeed the current president even more than the war effort.

"I think we'll manage," the President said. "We just need to show that were aren't subordinates in the Alliance. Partners, not subjects of princesses and queens, both alien and on Earth." He

smiled at SG-1. “And that’s where you come in. Especially you, Captain Carter.”

Jack saw that Carter, who had been relaxing a little since she had given her report on the technological aspect of this whole thing, tensed. “Sir?”

“We’ll need to emphasise your relationship with Princess Entrapta. Your professional relationship, I mean - the last thing we need are rumours of an unprofessional relationship with her.”

Carter blinked. “What?”

“That would feed the lunatics prattling about alien corruption,” the Secretary of Defense commented.

“I do not have or had a sexual relationship with Princess Entrapta,” Carter spat. “Sir.”

The President had the grace to wince at that, but the Secretary of the Interior went on: “Yes, yes. But that doesn’t matter. What matters is what the public thinks. And if they think there’s a torrid affair between you two, that won’t be received well.”

“I thought the entire point of the latest amendment was to legalise and normalise all gay relationships,” Daniel commented with a frown.

“Yes. But we can’t ignore that a significant part of the public still has some reservations about the whole thing. We don’t want to… push too much,” the man continued.

“And we don’t want rumours in the Armed Forces that you were… exploiting this,” the Secretary of Defense added.

Jack clenched his teeth. Carter looked angrier than he had seen her before. He glared at the cabinet members. “Are we really planning to pander to the bigots with an overly active imagination?”

"Of course not!" the Vice President protested. "We're just concerned with the optics. We don't want you to get hurt over this."

Kinsey spoke up: "I'll do what I can to squash such attempts."

"Thank you." The President nodded at him. "So, what kind of concessions can we get, other than the technology? Bases?"

"We can offer desert training, probably mountain training facilities as well," the Secretary of Defense suggested.

"That sounds like a good start."

While the cabinet discussed this, Jack looked at Carter. She was still fuming. And all he could do was nod at her to show his support.

He really hated politics.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, November 26th, 1998

She shouldn't be here. She should be back at Stargate Command, helping Entrapta and Sam find a way to get the Goa'uld out of Lieutenant Lenkova. Adora had expelled Horde Prime from Hordak's body, after all, even if exactly how she had done it was a bit hazy. And, according to the data gathered by Entrapta, Adora had healed people infected by parasites before. Of course, that had been when she had healed everyone in the area in the surge from Earth's returning magic, but there was no reason she couldn't do that normally. As long as she was prepared to heal the poison Goa'uld could release. Which she was reasonably sure she was - she had healed poison before.

On the other hand, they didn't know whether or not Adora's healing had expelled or killed the Earth parasites; the records from India were not conclusive. If she tried it and the Goa'uld

died, that would be... Well, it was one thing to kill an enemy in battle, but it was another to kill them when they were your helpless prisoner.

Looking out of the window in the White House, she repeated herself out loud with a sigh: "I shouldn't be here."

"The protesters outside would agree with that," Glimmer told her. "But they're wrong." Adora's friend got up from her seat and joined her at the window.

One could barely see the people protesting the alliance negotiations - tall barriers at the fence blocked the line of sight. Supposedly for safety reasons. Glimmer thought, and Catra agreed, that this was just a pretext so the American government could pretend there weren't any protesters without infringing on their rights to protest or something. Adora had seen them when they had arrived, anyway. And heard them.

"This is important," Glimmer said in a lower voice.

"So is saving Lieutenant Lenkova," Adora retorted.

"We're working on that."

They were. Entrapta, Melog and Catra were back at Stargate Command. But Adora wasn't. And she was the best Healer on Earth. "You don't need me here."

"Yes, we do," Glimmer protested.

"You can handle politics," Adora pointed out. "And military matters." This was just an 'introductory meeting', as someone had called it - even though they already knew the United States government.

"I could." Glimmer nodded. "But it's easier if we do it together."

Right. Adora bit her lower lip. Leaving Glimmer to do everything by herself was selfish. Adora was needed here as well. If only Bow

wasn't busy helping Hordak build the spacelab… No, she couldn't think like that.

"It'll be hard enough to keep smiling when they make stupid demands to puff themselves up," Glimmer went on.

Adora pressed her lips together. Why couldn't people work together without trying to get an advantage for themselves at the expense of others? "I hate that part," she hissed.

"I hate it too," Glimmer said with a shrug. "But it's necessary."

"It wouldn't be necessary if people weren't so selfish," Adora spat.

"But people are selfish. And vain. And envious." Glimmer snorted. "It's not very different from the early Alliance meetings."

Adora had heard that before, but she couldn't really believe that things had been as bad as that.

Glimmer grinned. "You've only seen us when the war was going so badly, everyone realised that they couldn't afford to play such games. It was different before. Dad told me about it as well - most princesses of his generation were almost as concerned with ensuring that another kingdom didn't get an 'unfair advantage' as they were with winning the war."

"And they almost lost the war," Adora pointed out. "We should focus on defeating the enemy!"

Glimmer grimaced. "We can't just focus on winning the war. We also need to prepare for peace after the war. An alliance only held together by a common enemy won't last once the enemy is defeated. We need to build ties and friendships beyond that."

That was obviously true, but… "And we get that by squabbling over who gets which base?"

"We get that by ensuring that no one feels cheated or exploited, but part of something greater than themselves." Glimmer smiled a

little sadly. “At least that’s what Mom said, according to Dad.” She straightened. “And by ensuring that everyone gets something out of it when things are going well.”

Adora pouted. “I still don’t like it.”

“I know. You don’t have to like it.” Glimmer nodded again. “Don’t worry - I’ll handle most of the finer points of the negotiations and diplomacy. Just be yourself.”

Adora nodded. She could do that. In fact… She blinked. “Wait! ‘Just be yourself’?” After Glimmer’s speech about how important those negotiations were?

“Yes.”

Adora frowned. “You’re using me as… as… the bad cop!” Like in those Earth TV shows!

Glimmer grinned a bit sheepishly.

“I’m not the bad cop!” Adora insisted.

“Of course not - you’re not bad!” Glimmer told her. “You’re She-Ra. Princess of Power.”

“And you’re going to be the reasonable politician you can make deals with.”

“Yes.”

“We didn’t do that in Europe,” Adora pointed out.

“We didn’t have to. We only had to ensure that things worked out for the war. But the United States are almost as big as the rest of the Earth countries in the Alliance put together and arguably more powerful. And our other allies carry grudges about their past behaviour. So, we can’t just stay back and let things sort themselves out. Not without making everyone else mad. It’s just politics.”

Adora sighed. She really didn't like politics.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 26th, 1998

"Yes, we know how to safely separate symbiont and host, although the procedure is not without risk if the symbiont is unwilling." The supposed Tok'ra inclined his head. He didn't seem to be bothered by the fact that his allies hadn't replied to his message yet, and that he was still in a cell under guard.

He certainly looked much calmer than Samantha Carter felt. Just thinking of the rumours the cabinet had hinted at made her want to punch something. Or to repurpose something for destructive testing. It was the old malicious gossip about sleeping her way to a promotion, just with an added twist. And there wasn't much that she could do about it as long as it stayed just gossip - such attitudes were too ingrained in the Air Force. Or in society in general.

But she had a task to accomplish. "And if we sedated the parasite?"

The alien didn't react to her correction. And she had had an excellent argument prepared to point out that the Goa'uld were not symbionts; any benefits they provided to their hosts' bodies were only used by the Goa'uld, not the hosts who permanently lost control over their bodies. "It is an instinctive reaction, alas." He even looked like he regretted it. "We need to actively suppress the urge to release the toxin."

Sam pressed her lips together. That was awful but not quite unexpected.

Entrapta beamed. "That's interesting! I wonder why you evolved that way - was there once a danger of being forcefully extracted, so you developed ways to discourage that? Or did the toxin once have a different function, before you started taking humans as

hosts? Might it have been beneficial for your original hosts? Or were you engineered that way?"

And the Goa'uld finally frowned. "Why would you think that we were engineered?"

"Well, you look like a great infiltrator for a human civilisation. Not perfect, of course, since once you know how to scan for Naqadah, you can find your hosts. And we know the First Ones experimented with humans, so why wouldn't they experiment with your ancestors? Or created you through a process of hybridisation? Unless we can analyse the fauna of your home planet, we might never know. By the way, where is your home planet? Do you know that? Since you have genetic memories, you should know where your ancestors were born, right?"

"We evolved naturally on our home world," Jakar told them - he looked, if not disturbed, then at least annoyed. "We were not engineered as tools."

A potential psychological weakness? Sam made a mental note to look into this. They also knew their home world - or wanted the Alliance to believe that.

"Oh, being the product of genetic engineering is nothing to be ashamed of!" Entrapta smiled. "I'm the result of such experiments, you know! And the Jaffa, of course - though you really should have fixed their dependency on Goa'uld larvae for their immune system."

Sam clenched her teeth. She really liked Entrapta, but her friend's tendency to share crucial intel with everyone was annoying, to say the least. "The Ancients have a history of such experiments," she said, trying to mitigate the damage. "And in the time since their disappearance, many of their engineered species will have evolved over millions of years. However, we're here to find out how to extract a Goa'uld from one of our soldiers without killing her," she reminded Entrapta.

“Right! So, if we want to use your method, we need to counter the toxin,” Entrapta said. “That should be possible.”

“It is a neurotoxin, and since a symbiont is connected to the host’s central nervous system, death happens instantly as the toxin destroys the nervous tissue,” Jakar pointed out. He spread his hands. “I do not want to give you false hope. Honesty is the best policy to build trust.”

“Yes, that’s obvious, but that doesn’t mean that we can’t stop it. We just need to heal the neural tissue faster than the toxin can destroy it.” Entrapta nodded. “Although that would require constant healing, I guess, which could be tiring.”

The Goa’uld was shaking his head. “Even a sarcophagus cannot heal such brain damage. It was tried in the past, at great cost, and without result.”

“Oh, we’re not planning to use a sarcophagus,” Entrapta told him. “Although a regeneration effect like the one we encountered, modified so it doesn’t zombify the target, might work.”

The Colonel would throw a fit if they proposed that plan, Sam was sure of that. Even if it had potential. “There are alternatives.”

“We’ve been looking into this for millennia and haven’t found them,” Jakar retorted. He sounded rather arrogant to Sam.

“That means we’re breaking new ground!” Entrapta smiled again.

“You must come from a very advanced civilisation to be so confident,” Jakar commented.

“You’d think so, wouldn’t you?” Sam told him before Entrapta could spill more intel. “But the age of a civilisation doesn’t matter nearly as much as their approach to science.”

“Yes! If you convince yourself that something’s impossible just because others tell you so, you might miss out on so many interesting experiments - which can generate even more

interesting results!" Entrapta nodded emphatically. "And sometimes blow up a prototype or a lab, but that's the price we pay for doing science!"

Sam nodded - and noted that Jakar had stopped looking smug and vaguely patronising. Well, that made her feel better. Showing up the Goa'uld or Tok'ra was almost as good for restoring her mood as showing up the sexist bastards in the United States was.

She blinked at her own thought while Entrapta told Jakar about lab safety. It seemed that spending so much time with people who were raised in a very different culture, with different expectations of how men and women were to act, was influencing her more than she had thought.

*****

"Apophis is a false god."

"Traitor!"

Loyalty. Conviction.

Catra didn't take her eyes off the prisoner to glance at Melog, but she frowned. Yes, she had come to the same conclusion. You had to expect that kind of fanatic loyalty - even in kingdoms where the ruler wasn't worshipped as a god, only the most reliable soldiers would be sent to guard a biological weapons research facility. For the Goa'uld? Who would happily betray each other to take over? Apophis had to have picked the most loyal Jaffa to keep his underlings in line. But it was still disappointing.

"Apophis is a false god," Teal'c repeated himself. "He does not deserve your loyalty."

"I've heard of you, traitor!" the prisoner spat. "You betrayed our god! I will not listen to your lies!"

Catra snorted. "Well, you kind of are listening right now," she pointed out.

That earned her a glare as well, which she shrugged off with a grin.

Fool. Melog moved to her side.

"Aren't you wondering who we are?" Catra asked. She moved her ears for emphasis.

The prisoner remained silent.

"Apophis is no god. His powers are not divine but mere technology," Teal'c spoke up again after a moment. "He does not care for his followers - they are but tools to be used and discarded."

"The faithful will be rewarded in the afterlife!"

Fanatic.

Yeah, definitely.

"That is a lie. Apophis holds no power over the afterlife."

The prisoner remained silent again.

Catra shook her head. If things were pointless, she might as well try something weird. And have some fun. She stood up and walked around the table, towards the prisoner shackled to the steel chair, her tail swishing. "Apophis is a false god fooling his followers with tricks. He has no power over your soul." She flashed her fangs, then leaned over, extending one claw from her index finger. His eyes tracked her hand, and she saw him tense a bit. Grinning, she ran her claw over his forehead, then down his cheek, resting on his throat. "But others do."

She withdrew her claws, and the room around her grew dark, mist rolling up to her calves. Eerie music started to play in the background.

"Parlor tricks!" the prisoner spat.

But then the room vanished, replaced by an empty field of dry ground. And sand. A dark, starless sky above them. And a huge temple looming in the back.

The Jaffa jerked, gasping, and stared at Teal'c - or where he couldn't see him any more. Nor could he see Catra or Melog. He started to turn his head, looking around.

Catra snorted softly.

"Parlor tricks!" the prisoner repeated himself - but he sounded a little shaken.

Teal'c had narrowed his eyes a little, Catra noticed. Well, that was to be expected. She nodded at Melog, and the illusions faded.

Catra grinned at the prisoner, turned and left the interrogation room, Melog trailing after her.

Teal'c nodded at the other Jaffa, then followed her. Once the door closed, he tilted his head slightly. "That was not part of the plan."

"I improvised," Catra told him with a shrug. "He wasn't going to break. Too fanatical."

"I saw the truth, and I was Apophis's First Prime."

"Yeah, but you're not him. He's like that even after guarding a facility where people were killed to test weapons," Catra pointed out. "I know a bit about stupid fanaticism." Well, not the loyal kind, but still. "Takes a lot more to shake up his type."

"In a similar situation, I did the same - reassured me of my own loyalty to the false god to suppress my doubts." Teal'c nodded. "The Tau'ri have a saying - the man might be protesting too much."

"It's kind of hard to tell the difference between those and true believers," Catra retorted.

“Indeed.” Another small nod.

It was Catra’s turn to glare at him. His subtle humour wasn’t as funny as he thought. If it was humour. Melog was amused, at least, she could tell that. “Whatever - all we did was shake him up a bit.”

“By pretending to be gods.”

Ah, that was what he disliked. “We didn’t. None of us claimed to be a goddess or god.”

His eyebrows rose a little.

“If I really wanted him to find a new god, I’d have called Adora,” Catra told him.

“She would not be amused.”

“Oh, yes, she wouldn’t be amused.” Catra chuckled, imagining her lover’s reaction. “It would still be funny, though.” Adora had at least some of the power the Goa’uld claimed they had.

“We should not encourage faith in false gods.”

“But if they have to follow a god, it would be better if it’s a good one.” Catra shrugged. “Might be a human thing - most of them seem to follow a god.” And, from what she could tell from her admittedly limited exposure to human religion, she’d rather have everyone following Adora than any other religious figure. But saying so would be offensive, at least according to Glimmer.

And Adora would hate it, which was more important.

She shrugged again. “Well, we tried. Let’s check on the others. Can’t leave them unsupervised for too long, or they’ll try to turn Lenkova into some experiment.”

“I do not think Captain Carter would condone that.”

Catra smirked. "I think she would make an exception for Lenkova."

Teal'c tilted his head a bit to the side, which she took as agreement.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 27th, 1998

"...so, in order to create an antidote to the symbiote toxin, we need samples. And since we don't have any, that's kinda difficult." Entrapta nodded, then added: "Also, because the only way to get such a sample is to kill the Goa'uld in a host, presumably when the host is still alive, it's kind of unethical, so we can't do that." She smiled.

Jack O'Neill suppressed a sigh. The mad scientist princess looked like she expected a headpat and a 'well done' for realising that you didn't kill prisoners or innocents. Worse, the rest of the Etherians smiled at her.

"Yes." Carter stood and pointed at the hologram of a snake they had floating inside the meeting room. "Even assuming we had an antidote, surgical removal is very difficult because the Goa'uld is wrapped around the host's spine and connected to their central nervous system. Any damage to either is likely crippling or fatal."

"I can heal that!" Adora spoke up. "I mean, the crippling damage - not the fatal one, obviously." She nodded emphatically.

'Obviously'? Jack narrowed his eyes slightly. It sounded a little… overly emphasised for Adora. And the way the other Etherians didn't react at all… He pressed his lips together. He didn't want to deal with that worrying possibility right now. At least he was sure he had been alive when he had been healed by her.

"However," Carter went on, "with magical healing available, it remains a potential solution. But we think alternatives should be pursued first."

Adora nodded again.

"Basically, we need to find out if Adora can expel the Goa'uld without killing either them or the host," Entrapta said. "Although, since she can heal them, death should be off the table anyway in either case. Probably. It depends on whether or not the magic of She-Ra would consider the Go'auld a healing target in this case - a symbiont - or a parasite to be removed." She cocked her head to the side as her hair pointed at the hologram. "Answering that question would be useful for a better understanding of the Goa'uld's biology, I believe."

A symbiont? Jack scoffed under his breath. The damn snakes were parasites. And he didn't give a damn about whether or not they lived as long as they were removed from their hosts.

But he wasn't calling the shots here. The generals present were.

And Haig was nodding. "I see. And if you attempt to use magical healing to expel the Goa'uld, and it is healed instead, it might wake up."

"And attempt to kill their host by suicide," Carter added. "Which, in this case, magical healing might only delay and not stop permanently since both host and Goa'uld would be healed at the same time, allowing the Goa'uld to continue the attempt indefinitely."

"Or until Adora stops healing them," Entrapta added.

Which she wouldn't do voluntarily. Jack knew her well enough. And losing Lenkova like that would probably not do good things to her mental health. Not at all.

"So, the best option seems to be to attempt magical healing, and if the Goa'uld isn't expelled from the host, sedate it at once." Entrapta waved her hair, and a cartoon syringe appeared on the hologram, pointed at the Goa'uld.

“However,” Carter took over, facing the row of generals in the room, “There are serious ethical considerations with this course of action. There is a significant probability that the attempt might lead to the Goa’uld’s death.”

“So?” Sidorov scoffed. “It’s an enemy currently possessing one of our soldiers.”

Jack really didn’t want to agree with the Russian, but he also didn’t want to value the life of a snake over that of Lenkova’s life or freedom.

“It would be killing a helpless prisoner,” Carter went on. She looked tense - she probably didn’t want to but agreed with the Russian as well, Jack realised. But she was also correct about killing prisoners.

Adora nodded again. Sharply. “Yes. We can’t just kill prisoners.” She didn’t sound conflicted. Not at all.

“One could argue that the Goa’uld is still actively fighting by holding one of our soldiers hostage,” Petit suggested.

“They’re unconscious,” Adora retorted. “They might be willing to surrender peacefully and let Lieutenant Lenkova regain control of her body if we ask.”

Jack scoffed. As if! The snake would attempt to deceive and betray them at once.

Catra glared at him while Adora frowned. Hey! He was just stating the obvious - well, not stating actually, more making it known without words.

“How likely do you think such an outcome is, Captain?” General Haig asked.

“It isn’t very likely, sir,” Carter told him. “But we cannot dismiss the possibility.”

“We’re at war,” Sidorov said as if that explained and excused everything. “We cannot afford to coddle our enemies.”

“We cannot murder prisoners,” Carter retorted.

Jack clenched his jaws to avoid quipping about ‘we could, but we aren’t supposed to’. A dead snake was a small price to pay to save a soldier.

“We won’t murder prisoners,” Adora said with a deep scowl.

“But what about Lieuenant Lenkova? Are we willing to sacrifice her - doom her to a fate worse than death - to protect her assailant?” Petit countered.

It was Adora’s turn to wince. But she shook her head with a determined expression. “Murdering helpless people is wrong.”

“The Goa’auld aren’t people,” Sidorov snapped.

“They are!” Adora protested. “And the Tok’ra prove that they aren’t all evil.”

“Uh…” Entrapta spoke up, looking uncomfortable. “Anyway, that’s why we should wait and contact the Tok’ra to see if they have a better way to deal with possession. Or if they have more data that we can use. After all, they were already active when magic was still around, so they might be familiar with magical healing.”

“We have a Tok’ra in our cells,” Petit pointed out.

“But Jakar isn’t a scientist,” Entrapta said. “He doesn’t know the details.”

“So, we should wait with attempting to remove the Goa’uld from Lieutenant Lenkova until we know more? Or at least know we won’t know more?” General Haig asked. “That sounds like a sensible solution to our dilemma.”

In other words, they would be waiting and doing nothing, hoping that a solution would magically appear. Well, it was prudent to wait for more information before you were risking someone's life, but Jack really hated waiting in this case.

Damn.

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The Experiment Part 2

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 28th, 1998

"...and we would offer a desert training facility and a mountain training facility in the United States."

Adora resisted the urge to roll her eyes. 'Offer' - as if the Secretary of Defense hadn't made it clear that this was actually a demand. Glimmer and Catra didn't even have to point that out to Adora. Not that she was as naive as they sometimes thought.

She just didn't like how politics took priority over military necessities. No matter how often Glimmer told her that politics were crucial for waging any war. It just… didn't feel right. Why couldn't people work together without all those games?

"Well, the desert training facility would certainly be welcome - the Alliance hasn't yet picked a site for that sort of training," Admiral Smythe, Royal Navy, said. "But, of course, we would have to discuss that with the rest of the Alliance."

"I thought we were here to discuss that," the Secretary of Defense retorted.

"Yes, but such a decision requires the agreement of our respective governments," General Dubois, French Army, said. "It is, after all, both a military and political decision."

Adora did roll her eyes now. She glanced at Glimmer, who had her 'I wish I could teleport you into the ocean, but I am restraining myself' smile on her face, then at Catra, who was…scratching something into the table?

Adora leaned to the side and tilted her head. Oh. It was a sketch of her and Adora. Cute!

But her good mood didn't last. They were here to settle things, not to posture. She cleared her throat. "I think that since we don't have a desert training facility available, it would only be logical to accept the offer."

Everyone smiled at her, but Adora doubted that everyone meant it. "Of course," the admiral said. "But we do have offers for mountain training - from several countries with long traditions of fighting in mountainous terrain."

"The United States 10th Mountain Division is an elite formation, proof that our facilities are not only adequate but well-suited," the American countered.

That sounded good enough for Adora. And Glimmer nodded. So, it probably made political sense as well.

"So, that's settled." The Secretary of Defense nodded, then pulled out another sheet. "Now, with regard to the central transport command, coordinating the Alliance supply routes, I think we have the ideal site in the United States - very well protected and available as soon as Stargate Command moves to its new location."

Smythe smiled. "You mean the ground component. The main command will be in orbit."

That surprised the American, Adora could tell. But it was logical that you should have some direct command post in orbit. But a ground-based backup would make sense as well. But it wouldn't be very prestigious, or so she understood.

"With our new shuttles," Dubois added, "it's an obvious choice."

The smile of the Secretary of Defense grew very thin. "And speaking of shuttles, with the number of soldiers the United States will add to the Alliance, it makes sense to build factories to ensure that they have the means to be moved at all times."

"We can expand our own without trouble," Dubois countered.

“Spreading out crucial factories makes sense,” Glimmer cut in. “Although I assume you’ll expand production anyway.”

“If you have the money,” someone muttered.

Which reminded Adora that they hadn’t settled the budget yet.

Things had been so much easier during the war against the Horde.

“And I thought Horde logistics were a pain in the butt,” Catra muttered.

Well, at least Adora wasn’t suffering alone. Even Glimmer didn’t like it here; Adora could tell.

She couldn’t help feeling a bit glad about that - Glimmer had called her here for the negotiations, after all.

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Half an hour later, they hadn’t made much, if any, progress.

“The industrial capacity of the United States should be used to the fullest. Economies of scale, experience and logistics all point towards one conclusion: That we should shoulder the biggest share of the Alliance’s supply needs.”

“We’re not in the Second World War any more. The advantages you claim aren’t unique to the United States. And with regards to logistics, we will be relying on Etherian ships for transport.”

“We’ve got the biggest arms industry. We’re the logical choice for mass-producing advanced technology.”

“I’ll put a German factory against an American one any day of the week and twice on Sunday.”

“You don’t work on Sundays!”

“Of course we do!”

“Our factories suffice to cover the needs of the current Alliance, and we can easily expand them to cover your needs as well.”

“Is that why half of NATO uses US arms instead of your products?”

“We all know why so many people bought your arms.”

“Because we offered the best deals.”

“Why don’t we let the market sort things out? See whose products are better than their competition?”

“You mean, see who can use bribes and political pressure most effectively to push their products on others?”

Adora stared. They couldn’t actually be suggesting that, could they? She looked at Catra.

Her lover narrowed her eyes. “Wait! Are you seriously suggesting that we use many different designs for the same role? At the front? Are you trying to kill our logistics?”

Adora nodded. “We need standardised designs.” It had been bad enough in the Princess Alliance during the war, with all the different forces and standards.

“Yes, but we need to ensure that the best design is chosen, and healthy competition between manufacturers is the best way to achieve that - it won us the Cold War, after all,” the Secretary of Defense claimed.

“It’s very impressive that you can say that with a straight face, given your history of military procurement,” the German Verteidigungsminister said. “We remember why we picked your products.”

“And why we decided to design our own planes,” the French Ministre added.

“I don’t think national pride should be the deciding motivation,” the American retorted.

“Really? I can’t believe *you* just said that!”

OK, this was getting a bit… un-diplomatic. Maybe telling everyone to stop being formal had been a mistake?

“Having people compete with their designs sounds good in theory, but it depends on an unbiased final decision,” Glimmer commented. “Would you like us to pick a design?”

Adora didn’t have to be able to read minds to know that most people present didn’t want that. “What about picking the best designers and working together?” she asked.

That sent them whispering to their generals and aides.

“That’s how we get walkers,” Catra mumbled. “We should have never let Entrapta watch those movies.”

That was… pretty likely, actually. “Those might be a good choice,” Adora whispered. “Better all-terrain capability.”

“Just make hovertanks instead,” Catra shot back. “Faster, and can travel over water and through swamps.”

“But not through woods.” There was a reason that tanks had generally fared so badly in the Whispering Woods, and bots hadn’t.

“Whatever. We need to stop this circus.”

She was right. Adora nodded.

“And who gets to pick the best designers? One from each country, no matter their quality?” The American spoke up.

“Of course not,” Adora shot back.

“And which team? We need a lot of different vehicles alone, not to mention ships.”

“One base design, with variants to cover different tasks, should do it. An advanced combat vehicle family!”

“What a coincidence that your industry is working on that exact project!”

Not again.

Glimmer stood. “Enough. We need to step up the production of shuttles and mobile force field generators - coupled with bots - and we need a competitive air and space fighter. Ground-based vehicles Earth already has more than enough. Once we have some combat experience, we’ll know more about what designs are actually needed in the war. So, we can set up more factories for that, in the USA as well as in Europe and Canada.”

That, at least, was met with agreement.

“And we need to start building ships,” the British admiral added.

“Yes, but that’s not as urgent,” Glimmer told him. “We have a fighter design from the Horde, but it’s meant to be flown by bots.”

And that meant it needed a lot of changes so people could fly it.

“Modifying it might be faster than designing one from scratch, and we can use the experience for the next model,” the German Minister pointed out.

“We should spread out production, though, so we’re not dependent on a single source,” the Secretary of Defense said.

That was just common sense, in Adora’s opinion.

“We should pick a remote area for testing advanced technology,” the American suggested. “Like a desert. It would make keeping

the technology from spies easier if there was just one location to protect."

"Like the base where you tried to hide the Etherian shuttle?" the British admiral asked with raised eyebrows. "Area 51?"

"It would be an ideal choice," the Secretary of Defense said with a grin.

"If not for the fact that it is under permanent surveillance by everyone. Having to transport every prototype there would also facilitate spying on it - by anyone. There are other options."

"You just want more money to develop your ex-soviet bases."

"There are good reasons to pick a location in Germany."

"Too close to Russia. France is more secure."

"Canada has vast tracts of land that are empty of people and could easily be sealed off."

"And it's buried in snow for half the year."

"That's a cliche."

"One based on facts."

Adora winced. Telling everyone to stop being formal had definitely been a mistake.

"I almost miss the Horde," Catra muttered. "No one talked back there."

Adora glared at her.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 29th, 1998

"...and Glimmer said we won't get to design a new fightercraft - an aerospace fighter, able to be used in space and in the atmosphere - yet. We'll adapt the Horde standard space fighter instead."

Entrapta looked a little disappointed, Samantha Carter noticed. She could understand that very well, of course - as a pilot, she certainly had spent some time designing her ideal fighter or at least defining all the features it should have. And what engineer could take a look at a Death Glider and not think of a better craft?

Of course, designing aircraft wasn't one of her specialities, although she certainly knew more about the engines and life support system an aerospace fighter should have, and about the performance of Death Gliders, than any engineer from Boeing or Lockheed Martin. Still, she had a lot of other projects to work on.

Which reminded her that she hadn't really worked on the alien data cube they had recovered months ago. And she wouldn't be able to do much work on it in the foreseeable future, either. Not with so many urgent problems to tackle.

Something she shared with Entrapta. "Well, we do have to finish our spacelab before we can take on other tasks," Sam said. It would also help with designing the Alliance Orbital Command Centre.

"Right! Hordak and Bow have finished constructing the outer hull and installing life support, but we need to furnish it! It'll be great! I've made plans for a hologram suite for the entire lab, so we can visit virtually even if we can't make time to visit physically!"

That sounded… well, just off-hand, Sam could think of several applications for that. Virtual meetings. No longer wasting time travelling and being made to wait so someone could feel important and powerful. Or visiting your family while deployed - with FTL communication, even the Mars mission's crew could still keep in contact like that. And, though she would never mention

that near the Colonel, all the possibilities for entertainment, especially games…

She smiled. “That’s a great idea.”

“Right?” Entrapta beamed at her. “It should work through a Stargate as well. Although, based on the data we have, keeping the gate open just for hologram projections would be a waste of energy if you could step through it instead.”

“And it would block the gate for other connections,” Sam agreed.

“That too, yes.” Entrapta shrugged. “Though once we have the communication chain set up, we wouldn’t need the Stargate for talking to other planets, even though the lag would likely limit holoprojection.”

“Yes.” And speaking of probe bots… Sam checked the production data. Still short of the expected number, but the automated factory was working as intended now.

“We still need the computer data to set up a Stargate on Etheria, by the way,” Entrapta said. “Glimmer told me that negotiations were busy with stupid posturing and money grabs, so it might take a bit longer to get that.”

Sam nodded but couldn’t help feeling guilty. The United States were the central actor - and issue - in the current negotiations, after all. And she had been advising the government about dealing with the Etherians. If Sam and the rest of SG-1 hadn’t done that, would the government be so stubborn? Probably, Sam told herself. And they would be more likely to push for too much. Still…

“Anyway,” Entrapta interrupted her thoughts, “I’ve also been talking to Adora about the Goa’uld, and we should test her healing on parasites that aren’t sapient.”

“We could use animal testing,” Sam said. Many stray dogs and cats had parasites. Not even PETA would be against that sort of

animal testing. At least she thought so.

"Right. As a first step, I guess."

"Yes." Finding a human with a parasite would be a little harder. At least without violating medical confidentiality - most would consider their condition embarrassing. "I can send an airman to the animal shelter in Colorado Springs and fetch a few dogs. Or cats." Sam blinked. Would Catra have issues with dogs or cats? It was a silly thought, but the woman was a little prickly under the best circumstances, and all the speculation about her 'nature' hadn't helped matters. Better safe than sorry. "What do you think would be better, dogs or cats?"

"I think we should take both, so we have more data," Entrapta replied.

That was a good point, of course. But not what Sam needed to know. "Does Catra have experience with either?"

Entrapta frowned. "Oh. I don't know." She beamed again. "So, we'll get even more data!"

Right. Sam should have seen that coming. Well, she was a little curious herself…

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, November 30th, 1998

As Samantha Carter found out the next day, while the question of whether or not Catra had issues with cats or dogs was still up in the air, dogs and cats definitely had issues with her. The animals, half a dozen of each - Stiler had erred on the side of 'too many' rather than 'too little' - had started to growl and hiss in their cages as soon as Catra, following Adora, had entered.

And Catra definitely had issues with that. "Stop playing nice with them, Adora," she snapped. "Can't you see that they want to bite

me?”

“They’re just confused,” Adora replied from where she was crouched, trying to goad a mangy-looking cat out of its cage with a bit of food.

“That’s not confused!” Catra retorted.

“Afraid then. You must smell like a big cat to them.”

“What?”

“Yes,” Entrapta chimed in. “They probably mistake you for a local predator. Although you probably are a local predator, all things considered. Anyway, according to the pet guide we got, this is typical behaviour when an animal is stressed and afraid.”

“Oh, poor little things!” Adora cooed. “Don’t worry, Catra might look mean, but she’s as cuddly as you-Ow!”

“See? I told you!” Catra shook her head, crossing her arms over her chest, as Adora sucked on the finger the cat had just scratched.

Sam was already getting the medkit. Those were ‘fresh strays’, after all - who knew what kind of health problems they had.

“Just heal the things and yourself,” Catra said.

“How can you be so callous? Look how cute they are! Their fur is all puffed up! Like yours when you get startled.”

“Don’t compare me to those animals!”

Sam cleared her throat. “Can we focus on the experiment? You can cuddle the animals afterwards.”

“I can?” Adora beamed at her.

The woman had grown up in the Horde, groomed as a child soldier from birth, Sam reminded herself. She hadn’t been

socialised like a typical girl on Earth. “If they let you,” she amended.

“I bet one ration that they won’t,” Catra said.

“Deal!”

They were betting rations? Sam shook her head. She could look into that later. The experiment came first.

*****

Catra didn’t like those… furballs. The barking and growling were annoying, and the hissing… well, she hated having to refrain from hissing back to teach the nuisance its place because the others would never let her forget it. But it was even more annoying to see Adora fuss over the stupid animals.

Not that Catra was jealous - Adora would never betray her. Not even when Catra deserved it. She had proven that over and over again during the war. And Catra wouldn’t betray that trust either. Still, she had to clench her teeth while listening to Adora talking to the little beasts.

“Oh, you poor thing! Worms and fleas! No worry, soon you’ll be free of them.”

Fleas? Catra took a step back, shuddering. She had no intention of repeating *that* particular lesson from cadet training. Just thinking of it made her fur itch. “Adora! Don’t touch it if it has fleas!”

“They shouldn’t bother Adora,” Entrapta cut in. “Parasites are often limited to specific host species, having evolved with them. Another reason that makes Goa’uld so interesting.”

Well, Catra didn’t know if she was different enough to not have to worry about fleas from those animals. And she wasn’t about to find out. “Whatever!” She took another few steps back, crossed her arms over her chest and glared at the stupid cat in the cage.

Who was still hissing at Adora even though Catra's lover had just fed her. Talk about ungrateful!

"We're ready for the experiment now," Sam spoke up. She sounded amused.

Catra narrowed her eyes at the woman - yes, Sam was smiling.

But Adora was finally standing up. And there it came. "For the Honour of Grayskull!"

Catra watched, almost basking in the sight as her lover transformed, her sword appearing in her hand. It was a magnificent sight she would never tire of as long as she lived.

"Oops. Sorry!"

"Don't worry, it's not your fault - a lab should have a higher ceiling. When you're moving to the new location, you need to ensure you've got a better room, Sam!"

"At least there wasn't an important powerline in the ceiling," Sam said.

Catra snickered. That wouldn't have happened in the Horde.

"Alright - monitors have been set up, bug scanners and containment fields are ready, we're scanning… thirty-seven fleas and five worms on that specimen," Entrapta announced. "Signs of malnutrition as well."

Catra shuddered again. The poor thing…

Then Adora pointed her sword at the hissing cat, and magical light engulfed it.

When the light faded, the cat looked confused. Catra rolled her eyes. "You've just been healed, idiot!" she snapped.

Which earned her another hiss. Dumb beast.

"Oh… there are still fleas on the specimen. But the worms in the intestinal tract are all gone. And I don't see… No, nothing left; the mass of the parasites must have been disintegrated," Entrapta said.

"I didn't remove the fleas?" Adora asked. She was looking at her sword as if it was defective.

"They weren't inside the cat's body," Sam pointed out. "That was likely the difference. Unless it's related to the species of the parasites."

"Hm. This requires more data! And we've got more test subjects!" Entrapta announced.

Adora nodded with her most earnest and determined expression, Catra noted. But she also noted how her lover looked at the healed cat - who was already scratching their ear again.

Catra sighed. "And let's give the beasts a flea bath. Or something." She just knew that Adora would hug and cuddle the things afterwards.

*****

"Ah! Aren't you the cutest?"

Catra closed her eyes and wished she could close her ears as well.

"So, the experiments showed that any internal parasites got removed - effectively disintegrated since we found no trace of them in the air outside, so they weren't just expelled. Which is, of course, a good thing so we won't have to worry about contamination by dead parasites," Entrapta said. "And the external parasites were untouched. Botflies apparently count as internal, by the way."

Catra shuddered once more and tried to forget that particular memory. She'd have to invest in bug spray if those things were

common. She focused on the discussion instead. “So, if Adora heals a host, she would kill the Goa’uld?” Adora would hate that.

“It’s a possible outcome,” Sam said, “However, we cannot say at this point if magic treats sapient and non-sapient parasites the same. Or if the Goa’uld are treated differently since they also provide some benefits to the host body. The symbiotic bacteria in the intestines haven’t been purged, after all.”

“So, we’re back at step one,” Catra summed up.

“Yes. If all parasites had been expelled alive, we would have had a solid hypothesis that Goa’uld would be treated the same, but…” Entrapta shrugged. “We need more testing, but we don’t have the right test subjects.”

“You’re purring just like Catra when I pet her!”

Catra clenched her teeth and snapped at Adora, who was sitting in the middle of the now suddenly friendly animals. “That’s private!”

“Oh! Sorry!” Adora had the grace to blush, at least.

But now the stupid animals were growling and hissing at her again.

This time, Catra flashed her fangs and hissed back.

“Catra! You’re scaring the poor things!”

That was the idea!

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 1st, 1998

“Hi, Jack! We’re adopting!”

“No, we’re not!”

“But Catra! She likes you!”

“She doesn’t. She just wants my food!”

“So give her some! She’s starving!”

“She already got half my sandwich!”

“Get another one!”

“Besides, that’s not good food for cats.”

“But you eat it, Catra!”

“I’m not a housecat!”

Jack O’Neill sighed and rubbed the bridge of his nose. “Can we focus on the subject of this meeting?” he ground out.

He half-expected Catra and Adora to ignore him, but Catra actually sat up straight and nodded. Adora followed her friend’s example. She looked serious when she nodded, but Jack had caught her sneaking the cat - barely older than a kitten, as far as he could tell - a treat or something, so he wasn’t sure how serious she actually was.

Well, he’d take what he could get. And hope that Hammond never heard of this - the General would enjoy seeing Jack trying to deal with such antics for a change. Though Jack had never brought a pet into a briefing. And speaking of that… “Why’s there a cat in the room?” he asked.

“You mean the housecat?” Adora asked.

Catra growled at her.

“Yes,” Jack said through not quite clenched teeth.

“She’s here to illustrate our experiment,” Entrapta piped up.

“And she has no one else to look after her,” Adora added.

“Which is her own fault,” Catra said. “She broke out of her carrier and hid in the lab before the rest were moved to new owners.”

“Exactly!”

Jack sighed again. “Was that why I got a mail asking if I wanted a dog?” He glanced at Carter, who was suspiciously silent and focused on her laptop.

“We asked everyone,” Entrapta said. “We were looking for good homes for our test subjects.”

“We couldn’t send them back to the shelter after the experiment,” Adora explained. “That would have broken their hearts.”

Jack slowly nodded and tried to ignore how the cat walked around the briefing room, sniffing at the trash can in the corner. “I see. And, speaking of experiments…?”

“Right.” Adora nodded sharply. “My healing destroys internal parasites but leaves external ones alive and in place.”

“And presumably healed them as well,” Carter added. “Though we could not determine whether or not this was true without the aid of a biologist.”

“Doctor Fraiser said she wasn’t equipped to check the health of fleas,” Entrapta pouted. “That’s a serious deficiency you should correct when you move to the new site. Also, we’ve been looking into mailing samples to specialists.”

Jack grinned at the thought of the doctor’s likely reaction to that request. “I see. So, any attempt to expel the snake from Lenkova would likely kill it?”

“We cannot dismiss that possibility,” Carter replied. “Although we don’t know enough about She-Ra’s magic to say with any certainty. It could treat sapient parasites differently.”

“And we can’t just risk killing helpless prisoners if there’s a possible alternative,” Adora said. She was dead serious now, Jack noted - she didn’t even react to the cat trying to climb into the trashcan. And it didn’t look like Catra was about to try to change her mind, either.

Damn.

“It’s not a critical situation,” Carter said. “Lieutenant Lenkova is still sedated, and, according to Janet, the Goa’uld’s presence is countering the negative effects of long-term sedation. However, due to the regenerative effect of the possession, Lenkova might be building up an immunity to the drugs used on her - they already had to up the dose once.”

So, time was starting to run out. Well, that was nothing new. In fact, Jack was used to dealing with more urgent problems.

“Is there any news from the Tok’ra?” Adora asked.

“Nothing so far. We’ve been checking the world twice per day,” Jack told her. “The next mission is scheduled for this afternoon.” Which would be another training mission for the new guys.

“Ah.”

“We still have other alternatives,” Carter said. “Although they would put Lenkova at a greater risk than the Goa’uld.”

Jack wasn’t about to risk the damn snake killing Lenkova if they could risk the snake’s life instead. And he was pretty sure most people agreed with that stance. But this wasn’t the time to say that. Not yet.

He nodded instead. “So, since we used this to get away from more boring meetings… is there anything else to discuss before we are sent back into the fray?”

“We’ll be opening our spacelab soon!” Entrapta announced. “Full remote and virtual access, too!”

“Waldos and hologram projections, sir,” Carter explained. Somewhat.

“And we’ll be testing a communication chain later - we’ve got enough probe bots now to start spreading them.” Entrapta beamed. “By networking them, they won’t ever feel lonely, either!”

“We’re not using sapient bots,” Carter answered Jack’s question before he could ask it.

“Ah, good.” There was no need to recreate Star Trek I. Although that might still happen. Not that Jack would mention that he had watched the movie when it came out - he had a reputation to maintain.

“If that’s all, then we need to go,” Adora said. “We need to buy pet supplies!”

“I told you - we’re not adopting her!”

“As far as I was told, you don’t adopt cats - they adopt you,” Adora retorted. “And she did!”

“That’s not how it works!”

“She must think you’re her big sister.”

“What? How? And why?”

Jack smirked.

Until he felt pinpricks of claws on his calf. Followed by some furry little beast climbing up his leg just as he was getting up.

Damn.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 2nd, 1998 (Earth Time)

“We need to name her,” Adora said, watching their cat - their kitten; she was still so small - chase a ball of crumpled tin foil across Darla’s lounge. She was so cute!

“We need to find her a good home on Earth,” Catra retorted. “We’re fighting a war; we can’t take care of a pet. A stupid pet, too.” She glared at the cat, who was now trying to shred the ball with her hindlegs. “That’s not alive, numbskull!”

Adora looked at Melog and grinned as they went up to the cat and licked it. “Look, Melog likes her as well.” And since Melog was so close to Catra, they usually shared their emotions…

Catra switched her glare to Adora. “It’s not about liking the stupid cat. It’s about what’s best for the cat. We can’t keep her on the ship.”

“Why not?” Adora asked. “Entrapta can build a catsitting-bot for us.” She had already asked. “We can have the bot watch and feed her when we’re not around.”

“And when we need to take Darla into battle?” Catra shot back with a frown. “Do you really want to risk her?”

“Ah! You do care about her!”

Her lover rolled her eyes. “That’s not the point.”

“It is,” Adora insisted. “We can take care of her.” She was She-Ra, Princess of Power. If she couldn’t take care of a small cat - a kitten - then how was she supposed to win a war and protect anyone else? “We don’t need to take Darla into a fight for now, anyway, and we can take her to Bright Moon before we start fleet operations.” She smiled at Catra, switching to a grin when her lover scowled in that ‘I hate losing an argument’ way of hers that was so familiar to anyone who knew her. Like Adora.

“And what if we’re pushed into battle before that?” Catra put both hands on her hips. “You can’t count on the Goa’uld just sitting on their butts until we start kicking them!”

"If they attack Earth, we've got Third Fleet here," Adora retorted. "And we'll be able to send her out with a shuttle to keep her safe if it comes to that." She cocked her head. "Do you really think we can't keep her safe? Between Earth and Etheria?"

Catra sighed. "I just don't… What if we can't? Neither you nor I ever had a pet. Swift Wind doesn't count," she added with a scowl. "It's a lot of responsibility."

"We've led armies. I think we can handle a pet," Adora said. How hard could it be?

"Soldiers aren't helpless. Not even Kyle." Catra crossed her arms over her chest, grabbing her elbows with her hands and looking to the side.

Oh. Adora smiled and stepped up to her lover, putting her hands on Catra's shoulders. "You'll do fine, Catra. Don't worry. Trust me. You can do this. We can do this."

Catra pressed her lips together for a moment, not meeting her eyes. Then she sighed. "And what about our friends?"

"What about them? They'll love her!" Even Jack, despite his cursing when the kitten had climbed up his leg, liked her. Adora was sure.

"They'll tease us about having a kitten."

Adora shrugged. "I'm sure it won't be too bad. And we can tease them back if they do."

"How?"

"They're just jealous they don't have a kitten."

Catra blinked, then sighed again. "They'll tease us about the cat being like our *baby*."

“Oh.” Adora could see that. And she, well… kind of understood it. Earth television had some shows about people using pets as replacement babies. “It’s not like that, though.” She released Catra’s shoulders, turning to look at the cat, who was still being licked by Melog. “And she’s worth a little teasing, right?” she asked while she wrapped her left arm around Catra’s waist.

Catra sighed yet again. “Well, yes. Maybe.”

That was a yes! “So, what should we name her? What name would she like?”

“Why are you asking me?” Catra cocked her head at her.

“Well…” Adora didn’t want to point out the obvious - her lover was a little prickly about some things.

Catra rolled her eyes. “I can’t *ask* her, dummy.”

Too bad. That would have made things easy. “So… Catty? Kitty?”

Catra put a hand on her face. “Really?”

“Catherine?” That was a decent name, wasn’t it?

“That sounds like a name for one of Entrapta’s bots.” Catra shook her head.

“That doesn’t make it a bad name,” Adora protested.

“She needs a better name,” Catra insisted. “If we’re going to have a pet, we’ll treat her right. And that means a good name.”

Adora frowned. Maybe this was a bit more difficult than she had thought. But at least Catra was on board now! “Princess?”

“No!”

“Luna?”

“Are you actually watching that show?” Catra stared at her.

"No!" Not really. Maybe an episode or two. But the blonde princess was too silly.

"What about…" Darla announcing an incoming call interrupted Adora. Perfect timing, she thought as she went to the bridge to take the call.

It was Stargate Command. The Tok'ra had answered the message. And they were requiring a meeting. And the return of Jakar.

Well, that was good news. Probably. Hopefully.

They'd soon find out, in any case.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 2nd, 1998

"This could be a trap - either by other Goa'uld factions or the Tok'ra themselves, for taking one of theirs prisoner. The demand to meet them on an unknown planet is suspicious."

Samantha Carter pressed her lips together. General Sidorov was as paranoid as ever. Or worse, actually.

General Haig, at least, remained unflappable as he replied: "Undoubtedly, meeting them on their terms carries a certain risk. However, this is also our best chance to open relations with a potential ally. They have been fighting the Goa'uld Empire for millennia, after all."

"I concur," General Petit agreed. "We can reconnoitre the planet in advance, I believe."

"That might offend the Tok'ra," General Li pointed out.

"I believe they will expect this level of caution by us," General Hammond retorted. "In fact, given what we know about them,

they might be offended, or at least might dismiss us as incompetent, if we didn't act with sufficient caution."

Sam agreed with that assessment.

So did the Colonel. "They're still snakes," he said.

Daniel cleared his throat. "We don't have enough data to draw conclusions. They might have a patronising attitude towards us - we have enough such examples in our history - but they might also be quite objective. Please don't forget that, according to what we know, they consider their hosts as partners. A society built upon such partnerships, for millennia, would naturally develop a different culture than a society built upon slavery and worship."

"Our information is based on the claims by the Tok'ra themselves," Sidorov said, scoffing. "We cannot trust their words."

"But we cannot treat them as untrustworthy either," Glimmer cut in. "We cannot build trust without offering some trust."

"By sending more soldiers into a trap? Soldiers who know our most important secrets?" Sidorov stared at Sam.

She clenched her teeth and sat even straighter in response. If the Russian thought that he could keep her from this mission… She had the most experience with Tok'ra. Very personal experience. Jolinar.

"If you want to send green troops on such an important mission, you're a fool," the Colonel snapped. "We're the ones with the experience to handle this." He nodded at Sam and the others, then at the Etherians. "And we've worked together before."

"Yes," Adora spoke up. "This is a great opportunity to make allies. We can't squander it."

Sam saw Catra lean over to Adora, mumbling something that Sam didn't catch but which had the other woman pout at her lover. She

forced herself to focus on the generals in the meeting room. “I think the risk is manageable, sir,” she told General Haig.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded several times, her hair bopping up and down. “And we can use this to test our improved spy bots! They should be able to do a deep scan of the area, possibly the planet if we give them enough time and send enough of them through the gate.”

“Trusting machines?” Sidorov spat.

“Do you trust anyone or anything?” Catra snorted.

“Of course not!” Sidorov said.

Not for the first time, Sam wondered why such a paranoid officer was on the Stargate Command Council. The Colonel said it was a Russian thing, but this seemed too simple an explanation.

General Haig spoke up again. “I think this would be a prudent course of action.”

“Yes!” Entrapta jumped up, fist raised, then pulled out her recorder. “Spy bot test number forty-five - planetary exploration. Six Mark Threes. Method of transport: Stargate. Objective: Scan for threats and anything else of interest.” She was already turning towards the door, obviously not intending to wait.

Sam looked at General Hammond. Entrapta could need some help - if only to handle the gate room crew - and Sam would rather do something productive than listen to the arguments in the meeting. The Colonel and the Etherians would ensure that SG-1 would be on the mission anyway.

Fortunately, he understood. “Please assist Princess Entrapta, Captain Carter.”

“Yes, sir.”

She caught up to Entrapta before they reached the gate room - right when the first spy bots walked and floated out of the elevator. Those were larger than the original Mark Ones but, of course, not nearly as large as the space-capable Mark Twos. Or the interstellar probe bots.

"Alright, guys!" Entrapta spoke up. "This is your first real mission, so I expect the best of you! But don't be sad if you have trouble - you are still in the testing phase, so you can't be expected to be perfect. Just do your best and gather data! And don't get destroyed!"

The bots beeped in agreement. One even trilled, rising a bit higher in the air, and Sam had to remind herself that those weren't sapient bots and this wasn't actual enthusiasm. Just a quirk of the programs.

She had checked that before, after all.

Running the last checks took some more time, but soon enough, the Stargate was establishing a connection, followed by six bots passing through.

Their sensors' feeds showed ruins around the gate as they fanned out.

"No power detected. No sign of life so far," Entrapta reported.

Sam double-checked the results, then nodded. "Yes. Preliminary scans complete."

"Looks clear," Entrapta said.

But that was just the gate area. They would have to scan far more of the planet, and of the atmosphere and orbits as well. One spy bot buried itself in the ground near the gate, the rest started to explore.

And Sam forced herself to focus on the alien surface she saw on the screen, on the data pouring in, on the bots' search patterns.

Anything to keep her from remembering her time as Jolinar’s host.

She gritted her teeth as she worked. She had the most experience with Tok’ra. She was needed. And she would do this, her personal demons be damned.

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The Tok’Ra Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 4th, 1998

Catra eyed the Stargate as it formed, taking care to appear as relaxed and unconcerned as she could. It wouldn’t do to look concerned or even anxious. Even though they were entering a potential trap. Sure, Entrapta and Sam’s bots had scanned the whole planet for two days before scanning the two people who had arrived twenty minutes ago. And anything that managed to escape their sensors would probably be able to bypass whatever security they might put up on another planet anyway.

But you could never be sure - Catra had used the Princess Prom, a supposedly neutral meeting, for a covert operation herself. In hindsight, that hadn’t been her best plan; it had driven the Kingdom of Snows into the Princess Alliance, but she had achieved her primary objectives. Mostly. Not that she wanted to remember that part of her life, anyway. With the exception of the dance, of course.

And who could say what the Tok’ra were planning? The First Ones had been willing to sacrifice Etheria to defeat Horde Prime. If the Goa’uld who had contacted them were even the Tok’a and not some other faction.

But being too cautious, seeing traps and traitors everywhere, was a good way to lose a war. Especially if you drove away allies. Catra was kind of familiar with that as well. And she didn’t want to look as stupid as the Russian idiot in Stargate Command, Sidorov. The odds that Jakar was working for a System Lord and had decided to pose as a Tok’ra in the spur of a moment, without knowing anything about the Alliance, were very low.

Besides, they had She-Ra and Entrapta with them. Whatever the trap, they’d beat it anyway.

So she smiled as she stepped on the ramp, flashing her fangs at the guards, then turned to glance at the others. “Come on, slowpokes! I want to be back in time for dinner. They’re serving fish in the mess hall today!”

“You could order fish every day,” Glimmer pointed out with a frown. “The payments from NASA for the Mars mission came in.”

“And?” Catra cocked her head to the side as if Glimmer had said something stupid.

“I mean… Oh, forget it!” Glimmer stomped past her, straight up to the gate. “Let’s not make them wait any longer.”

“Hey - they pick the place; we pick the time!” Catra retorted. Waiting until they arrived and then sending a bomb through the gate was the most effective way to ambush them that Catra could think of. Even Emily’s force shield would have trouble with a big enough bomb.

That was similar to how the humans had killed Ra, apparently.

But Glimmer was correct - they couldn’t wait any longer. Catra would have gone first through the gate, but her appearance might spook the Tok’ra since they were expecting humans. And if they attacked Catra, she’d have to defend herself, and that might ruin diplomatic relations before they could be opened.

So Catra let O’Neill go first, then followed him, holding her breath for the weird transit time. She was getting used to it, but it still played havoc with her senses.

And then she was on a new planet. PX-852, according to Stargate Command. And facing two Goa’uld. Or their human hosts. They didn’t wear heavy armour and were armed with zat’nik’tels at their hips, but while their uniforms looked quite tight, they and especially their belts could hide a lot of gadgets - or weapons. Catra knew that perfectly well. Flashing her fangs, she waved at the two women. “Hi!”

They were tense; she could tell at once. Catra wanted to ask if they had never seen a cat, but Adora and Glimmer, followed by Bow, Sam and Daniel, arrived right behind her.

And then came Entrapta with Emily, and the Tok'ra tensed even more. But, after a moment, they slowly nodded.

"Hello," O'Neill said. "I'm Colonel O'Neill, Stargate Command. These are Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, She-Ra, Princess of Power, Princess Entrapta of Dryl, Captain Carter, Techmaster Bow, Dr Daniel Jackson, Catra and Teal'c, former First Prime of Apophis."

"And this is Emily!" Entrapta added, patting the bot's upper shell. "Hi!"

Emily beeped.

"I am Garshaw of Belote. And this is Anise. We represent the Tok'ra," the Goa'uld with the darker hair said, nodding at the other.

Teal'c's eyebrows rose a little bit, Catra noticed. So, he must have recognised at least one of the names. The Goa'uld hadn't reacted to his presence, so they must have been already aware of his desertion.

"And we represent the Alliance," Glimmer replied.

"We expected Jakar to be present as well," Anise commented. She had a rather bland smile, Catra noted, but something in her attitude made Catra want to annoy her. Almost like a princess.

"Ah, yes, Jakar. Since he is in our custody, we're responsible for his safety, and so we can't risk transporting him into potentially dangerous situations until we are sure that there's no danger." O'Neill smiled, showing his teeth. "Wouldn't want to break our laws, you understand."

"Ah." Anise's smile didn't change, but she took a closer look at O'Neill.

Garshaw nodded. "You don't trust us."

"We don't know you," Glimmer said. "This meeting will hopefully change that."

Catra wasn't so sure about that. But she nodded along with everyone else.

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Gate Area, PX-852, December 4th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Jakar's message told us that you were potential allies against the Goa'uld. But he didn't tell us who you are," the darker-haired Goa'uld - Garshaw - said. She inclined her head. "We don't know you either."

Jack O'Neill had a snarky reply on his tongue, but Adora spoke up before he could: "We hope this meeting will change that as well." She had an earnest, wide smile on her face as well.

"You're clearly an advanced species - or an alliance of different species," the other Goa'uld said with a glance at Catra before staring at Entrapta with an expression that had Jack silently thank whoever was responsible that Hordak wasn't present and that the rumours about the princess and Carter were completely wrong. "This robot of yours looks very impressive. Is that a laser emitter?"

Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. "You saw that? Yes, it is! Standard bot weapon, though Emily's was upgraded, of course - couldn't leave you with sub-par weapons, right, Emily?"

Jack realised that he had been hanging out with the Etherians a bit too much since he could almost understand Emily's answering beep.

The Goa'uld gasped. "Oh! Is it actually sapient?"

"Emily's female, and yes!" Entrapta replied. "I programmed her matrix myself, and her neural network did the rest, of course."

"You did? Remarkable. Was this your technology, or did you adapt the Ancients'?"

"Oh, the control matrix is mine, but we've upgraded her with First Ones - Ancients - technology as well!"

"Though the details we shouldn't share until we know that we can trust each other," Carter cut in. She had a rather toothy smile, Jack noticed.

"Of course," Anise replied without taking her eyes off Emily. "Given your size, you must contain impressively powerful weapons."

Emily beeped in agreement.

Jack glanced at the others. Everyone else, even the second Goa'uld - or Tok'ra - looked like they were wondering when their diplomatic meeting had changed into a robot discussion. He cleared his throat. Time to be the bad guy. "So… That's very fascinating, but, as was pointed out, we shouldn't talk tech until we know each other much better." He flashed a toothy smile of his own at the two snakes.

"Oh, yes." The other Goa'uld sounded almost relieved. "I apologise for my companion - she is an excellent and passionate scientist, so new technology tends to fascinate her." Jack could hear the unsaid 'a bit too much' clearly.

Anise didn't deny that. She didn't even acknowledge it.

"Right. We don't share technology unless it's an alliance," Entrapta said. "Sorry!"

"Perfectly understandable," Anise told her.

Carter nodded politely. At least she could be trusted not to hand out military technology just for being asked.

"So, you're the Tok'ra," Jack said. "You opposed Ra, and I guess after we killed him, you switched targets."

"We heard that Ra was killed by the Tau'ri," Garshaw looked at him and raised one eyebrow.

"Yep, that's us," Jack said. "We had a slight disagreement. He wanted to conquer our planet, and we didn't want him to. So, we ended up blowing him up as a compromise."

"And you destroyed two Ha'taks in the service of Apophis," Anise added. "You must have quite the advanced technology - developed under Ra's nose."

"Yes." Jack smiled. "And that was before we joined the Alliance." No need to go into details here. As a member of Stargate Command, he was talking for Earth, or at least for two countries that were in the Alliance, and Carter had developed quite impressive technology from their finds, so, technically, he wasn't lying to the snakes. Not that lying wouldn't be a-ok when talking to snakes - or doing diplomacy.

"We represent the Princess Alliance. We met the Tau'ri shortly after Apophis's attack on their planet," Glimmer said. Of course, she'd have a different view of diplomacy. "When we learned of the Goa'uld Empire and their policies, we knew we would have to fight them and free their slaves. And so we formed an alliance. A new Alliance - Earth didn't join the Princess Alliance."

"Ah." Garshaw nodded.

"An alliance with an alliance? A complex arrangement," Anise said. She seemed to approve.

"We've never heard of a Princess Alliance." Garshaw seemed to ignore her friend's comment. "And we have access to almost all of the Goa'uld Empire's records."

“Have you heard of Horde Prime?” Glimmer asked.

They had - Jack saw them tense up.

“We defeated him,” Glimmer quickly explained.

“Thoroughly,” Catra added.

“That’s quite a claim,” Garshaw said. “Ra had ordered the System Lords to avoid Horde Prime’s territory. He kept the reasons secret from most of his followers, but we managed to find reports that told us enough to deduce that Horde Prime was exceedingly dangerous.”

“Yeah, we’re aware of that,” Jack cut in. “But Ra’s dead, and Horde Prime is dead. And the Alliance is just getting started.”

Daniel frowned at him, even though this was a great line.

“And how exactly did you kill either?”

That was a good question. One Jack wanted to answer with ‘that’s classified’, but he had a feeling that the Etherians would disagree. And looking at Adora raise her chin, he knew he was right.

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“For Horde Prime, I drove his spirit out of the body he possessed and destroyed it.” A moment after Adora had said it, she realised that the Tok’ra were probably a bit concerned about her wording. Or more than a bit, she amended her thoughts after she saw them tense up again.

“You destroyed his spirit?” Garshaw asked.

“Yes. He could jump from body to body. He wasn’t like you,” Adora tried to explain.

While Garshaw looked sceptical, Anise looked interested. “He was essentially a pure consciousness? One not tied to a physical body

like a Goa'uld or Tok'ra?"

"Essentially, yes," Entrapta said. "He basically took over prepared clone bodies, suppressing the native consciousness. Although his control wasn't perfect," she added with a fond smile. "In at least one case, his host could resist him."

"And Ra?"

"We lost a bomb in his flagship," Jack said, shrugging. "He must have stumbled over it."

"It sounds as if you're leaving out a lot of details," Anise commented.

"Boring details." Jack grinned.

"The details don't matter much here. What matters is that Horde Prime's dead and gone," Catra cut in. "The Goa'uld Empire still stands. The Tok'ra oppose it - or so we hear." Adora saw her lover's tail switch back and forth and her ears twitch a little. She didn't like sharing intel like that. But they couldn't expect anyone to trust them without showing some trust first.

"We have been fighting the Goa'uld for millennia," Garshaw replied with narrowed eyes. "None has hurt them as much as we did."

"But not in open warfare," Catra retorted. "You can't match them militarily."

"And you can?" Garshaw shot back.

"We believe so," Adora said. "We have better technology, and we will have the edge in trained troops." It was a risk to say this - but honesty was the best way to gain allies. And she had a good feeling about this.

"If you can match the Empire in open warfare, why are you seeking allies?" Garshaw didn't scoff, but Adora thought she wanted to.

“The more members in the Alliance, the easier the fight will be,” Adora explained. “Everyone has different strengths and weaknesses, but combined, we can cover each other. We can be more than the sum of our parts.” She smiled at them. This had to work - they had to see that this was true. “We can do so much more with allies than alone.”

“Or you can be dragged into futile attacks by ignorant allies - or be betrayed by your supposed allies,” Garshaw retorted. “We’ve seen this before, and the cost was horrible.”

Right. She was talking to people who have lived for thousands of years, Adora reminded herself. People who weren’t like Madame Razz. “That’s why we want allies. The more we know, the better we can plan. And we won’t betray our allies.” She nodded sharply, meeting their eyes.

“And the more we know, the better we can leverage our advantages,” Catra added. “And the lower the risk of killing your people as collateral damage is.” She shrugged. “It’s not as if we have a way to check if someone’s Tok’ra or Goa’uld when we attack a world.”

“Exposing our agents and spies to outsiders would endanger them far more than the chance that they might be caught in an attack by someone else,” Garshaw said. “All it would take is one succumbing to a Goa’uld, and the System Lords would be able to eliminate all our agents. We keep that information compartmentalised even within the Tok’ra.”

Adora refrained from frowning. It made sense.

“We don’t expect a list of your operatives - though we wouldn’t turn one down either, of course!” Jack grinned. “But if we had an alliance, or at least shared intel, we could confirm that a prisoner claiming to be Tok’ra was actually a member of the Tok’ra. Letting anyone go just on their say so isn’t how things are done, after all.” He shrugged. “Of course, we still don’t know if you’re the Tok’ra.”

Adora frowned at him. He wasn't wrong, but the chances that Jakar was a Goa'uld spy posing as a Tok'ra were rather small. He wouldn't have known who he was talking to, nor that the Alliance would work with the Tok'ra but would refuse to work with another System Lord against Apophis. Or that the Alliance wouldn't just torture him until he broke no matter his claims. And she didn't think he would have prearranged secret tells to let his allies know with a message that they would have to pose as Tok'ra.

"How do you expect us to prove our claims?" Garshaw asked. Her friend glanced at her, but she didn't seem to react. "Anyone could say they were members of the Tok'ra, after all. And why should *we* trust you? We are here because of Jakar's message, yet he isn't here. You admitted that you keep him prisoner."

How could you prove that you were honest? Adora glanced at Sam. They had a way, of course, but they didn't know if it would work. And the Tok'ra had a point about Jakar. She looked at Jack. "We can bring Jakar through the gate." It wasn't as if Jakar knew more about them than what they had told the Tok'ra about the Alliance. Quite the contrary, actually. Which she was sure Jack wasn't happy about. And she knew that Catra didn't like it. But trust required trust. Someone had to make the first step.

Jack narrowed his eyes, and his smile dimmed a lot, but, after a moment, he nodded and pushed a button on his radio. "Send Jakar through."

Stargate Command didn't argue. Adora sorted - that probably meant that Sidorov wasn't in the gate room.

A few minutes later, Jakar stepped through the gate.

"Jakar!" Anise smiled at him.

"Garshaw. Anise." He nodded at both, then looked at Jack.

"Go ahead," Jack said. "They already know more about us than you do."

Jakar laughed at this but walked over to the two other Tok'ra. They exchanged some words in a whisper that Adora didn't catch, but Catra did. Her lover shook her head, though, when Adora looked at her. So, she didn't understand the language. Well, Emily would have recorded it too.

Jack cleared his throat. "So, now that we've proven our good intentions, how about you prove that you're the Tok'ra? Just for the record, so to speak. I mean, if we really thought you were Goa'uld, we wouldn't have done this, but we've got a few sceptics at home, and we would like some solid proof that we didn't just spill all this intel to the enemy."

Yes, definitely not happy.

"Again: How do you expect us to prove that?" Garshaw asked

Sam took a step forward. "Call Martouf."

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"Martouf?" Garshaw tilted her head slightly as if she was confused, Samantha Carter saw, but Anise wasn't quite as smooth and froze for a moment. So, they knew the name. And they were surprised that Sam knew the name. Jakar didn't react - but he was a trained undercover operative, so Sam hadn't expected him to do so.

"Martouf," Sam repeated herself, meeting their eyes. "You know them."

"How do you know him?" Anise asked with a frown.

"That's part of how we can ascertain that you're Tok'ra," Sam told her.

"I see." Garshaw slowly nodded. "We will have to use the Chappa'ai to call him."

"And, of course, two of us will be staying here as a show of good faith," Jakar added, smiling widely.

He really wanted the alliance, Sam realised. Or, she amended her thought, he was that curious about them and the Etherians.

She also noticed that Garshaw wasn't happy, but Anise nodded. "Of course." The woman sounded almost eager. Well, Sam could understand that - any scientist worth her salt would love to observe, if not explore, new technology.

"It will take a while to reach him," Garshaw said, a very thin smile on her face. "You'll understand that I won't travel directly to him."

Sam hesitated a moment. This was a gamble. She was acting on partial information - information gained in a dream, based on remnants of Jolinar's memories. Disturbing dreams. And yet, Martouf was real. So she smiled and recited the gate address Jolinar and Martouf had used in the fragment of the Tok'ra's memories she remembered.

And Sam had to refrain from smirking at the Tok'ra's reaction. This time, even Jakar tensed, eyes narrowing for half a second before he started to smile again.

"Well played, Captain Carter," he said with a slight bow. "Your talents go beyond being a scientist and soldier."

Garshaw was less graceful - her lips were pressed together, forming a thin line, as she nodded. And Anise was… well, Sam wasn't quite sure what her expression meant. But the Tok'ra was staring at her just like she had been staring at Entrapta before.

Which did, strangely, make Sam feel proud and concerned at the same time.

Garshaw walked over to the D.H.D. with the usual grace of a Goa'uld not trying to hide, and the Colonel took a step to the side, his nod turning into an ironic bow. "I'll signal our side to break the

connection," he said, just as Garshaw opened her mouth, presumably to demand the same thing.

Sam once more refrained from grinning.

But as Garshaw dialled, the Colonel stepped closer to Sam and whispered: "That was a hell of a shot in the dark, Carter."

"It was a calculated risk based on solid intel," she retorted in an equally low voice. Well, as solid as possible for this situation, she amended in her mind.

Catra snorted - the catwoman had overheard them, of course.

"I hope you know what you are doing," the Colonel went on.

"Yes, sir," Sam replied. In any case, the die was cast.

Then Garshaw vanished through the Stargate, the connection ending a moment later. Sam took note of that. If the connection had stayed up, they wouldn't have been able to dial home. So, since Anise and Jakar were still here, this was also a sign of trust. Or it could be just a precaution in case the Tok'ra didn't have an iris or another way to block gate travel. She couldn't be sure until she personally verified it.

Sam understood why the Colonel liked to complain so much about spooks.

"So, while we wait…." Anise tilted her head and smiled at Entrapta. "Your hair looks very interesting. How do you control it?"

"Well, like I control the rest of my body," Entrapta answered. "With my mind."

"The hair is part of your body?"

"Yes." Entrapta nodded. "It's not the most powerful talent, but it's very useful for fiddly work."

Anise looked from her to Catra and back. “You are a very diverse Alliance.”

That, of course, had the Colonel chuckling. “You could say that, yes.”

Anise frowned at him for a moment, her lips twisting into a pout. Then her expression smoothed out again. “You four wear the same uniforms - a distinctive style.” She nodded at SG-1. “Even the former First Prime of Apophis. And yet, the rest of you all wear different clothes. And it is not for utilitarian reasons.”

Glimmer nodded. “Many different factions form our Alliance.”

“Do you have a dominant power? Or do you need to reach a consensus for every decision?” Anise asked.

“It depends on the kind of decision,” Glimmer told her. “Military decisions are under the purview of the military leadership - the commander of the Alliance forces and their staff.”

Which would have to expand, now that the United States was joining. Sam really didn’t want to watch those negotiations. Even though anyone with a working brain would have to realise that there was no chance at all that the supreme commander would be anyone other than Adora. Certainly not an American.

“Your planning meetings must be… lively.” Anise smiled in a way that made Sam want to take her down a peg. Even if the Tok’ra wasn’t entirely wrong about this.

“We manage,” Glimmer said. “Fighting Horde Prime taught us a lot.”

“Ah.”

“I am sure both of us can learn a lot from each other.” Jakar smiled again.

"Yeah, sure, you betcha. But let's focus on how to defeat the Goa'uld, shall we?" The Colonel cut in. "And we should wait with forming *closer ties* until we both trust each other."

Sam nodded. That was just common sense.

"Of course," Jakar replied, acknowledging the point. "Although I remain very hopeful that we will forge close bonds." His smile turned a little wistful. "We've been fighting the Goa'uld for a long time without allies. Of course, being betrayed by System Lords claiming they wanted to work with us did sour us on alliances with any Goa'uld. And we haven't been looking for other allies either."

"Yeah, being stabbed in the back by snakes does have that effect on people." The Colonel sounded a little too casual for simply agreeing with the Tok'ra, in Sam's opinion.

Daniel, who had been uncharacteristically silent until now, cleared his throat. "I noticed that you talk about the Goa'uld being your enemies, not the System Lords. Do you consider yourself as not part of the Goa'uld?"

"Yes." Jakar nodded sharply. As did Anise. "To call us Goa'uld is an insult," he added.

"Ah. I am sorry - I did not want to give offence." Daniel nodded but quickly perked up. "So, do you have a name for your species? That is, do you consider yourself an entirely new species defined by your allegiance?"

"We're the Tok'ra," Jakar said, a little less congenial than he usually talked, Sam noted.

Anise, though, nodded. "Indeed, I have coined a new term for our biological species, but, so far, it has not received wide acceptance despite the clear need to differentiate between cultural and biological terms."

Jakar tilted his head towards her. "The only one who has accepted it is you, Anise."

Anise sniffed in response. “That others reject my proposal is a clear indication of their lesser status as scientists. You cannot ignore that we are biologically the same species and so we should have a term for this.”

“Yes!” Entrapta chimed in. “Science is not biased or political - science is honest. You can’t do science if you’re not honest. You’d end up falsifying your data, undermining your entire work!”

“Exactly!” Anise smiled at her.

They had a very valid point, of course.

“Yeah, but sometimes, science needs to take those other things into account,” the Colonel said. “Or you end up with stuff that should never have been created and a whole mess on your hands.”

“Such as the research I destroyed before we met, yes,” Jakar agreed.

Entrapta frowned. “That’s wrong! Whether or not you use something is not a scientific question. You shouldn’t limit scientific research just because of politics! Researching doesn’t harm anyone.” She blinked. “If conducted properly and responsibly, of course,” she added with a smile.

The Colonel wasn’t the only one who grimaced at that. “Yeah, well… If you never build a world-destroying thingie, it can’t be used to destroy the world. And it can’t get stolen or lost. Or accidentally activated.”

Entrapta winced at that. As did the other Etherians. They would remember their past, Sam knew. She shook her head as she spoke up: “On the other hand, science is universal. Just because someone is limiting their research doesn’t mean anyone else will be doing the same. And people cannot defend against something unless they know how it works.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “That’s why we need to research everything! So we’re ready for everything!”

Well, that wasn’t a very practical stance. You couldn’t research everything - you would end up not researching anything in sufficient depth to be useful and practical. And there were only so many scientists with the talent and training to research advanced technology, much less to break new ground. They were fortunate that the Goa’uld kept their slaves ignorant as a rule - if the Alliance were faced with a Goa’uld Empire using its resources for research and development on a similar scale to Earth… Sam suppressed a shudder.

Anise, once again, was agreeing emphatically. “I keep telling the High Council the same! And they keep rejecting my proposals.”

For a moment, Sam felt for the other woman. The number of requests she had been denied during her career… Although, to be fair, those had mainly been denied for budgetary reasons, not on moral grounds. Or because her hide-bound superiours had favoured another, usually male, scientist. But on the whole, the United States Armed Forces were generally very open to anything that could improve their weapons.

She noticed that the Colonel was frowning at her. And the Etherians were staring at Entrapta and Anise.

Oh.

But before she could explain - or defend - her position, the Stargate activated again.

“Stay sharp!” the Colonel snapped, raising his M4.

“Shield up, Emily!” Entrapta yelled as the bot moved to cover them, force shields springing up.

But it was only Garshaw who stepped through, followed by…

“Martouf,” Sam whispered before she could stop herself. Her friend. Her comrade. They had fought side by side against the Goa’uld, and… No. She shook her head. She had never met the Tok’ra. This was Jolinar’s remaining memories affecting her.

She straightened and stepped forward, meeting the man’s eyes. “Martouf.” She bowed slightly to him in greeting.

He returned the bow, looking wary. “You know my name. But I have never met you,” he said with a glance at Garshaw.

“I know.” Sam smiled ruefully. “I was briefly the host of Jolinar of Malkshur.”

Martouf’s eyes widened as he drew a sharp breath. “Jolinar. Where is he?”

He sounded so hopeful... Sam pressed her lips together. She hated this. She forced herself to smile gently. “He died saving my life.”

“Oh.”

“But he was... inside me long enough for our memories to partially overlap. I remember you,” Sam went on.

“That’s how you knew the gate address!” Anise exclaimed.

Sam nodded. She turned to the Colonel. “They’re the Tok’ra,” she said. The odds of the Goa’uld being able to produce either Martouf or a double of his host in such a short time were too low to be considered a valid hypothesis.

He looked at her for a moment before nodding. “Okay. So, you’re the Tok’ra. We’re the Alliance. And we both hate the Goa’uld. Let’s talk!”

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Finally! Catra refrained from saying so out loud, of course - except for sighing a bit more loudly than usual, which earned her a frown from Adora. She stared back at her lover. Catra would have preferred to move with more caution - you couldn't trust just anyone you met who claimed to be fighting the Goa'uld - but if you were doing the trusting bit instead anyway, there wasn't any reason to stall for so long. It wasn't as if Entrapta was particularly good at keeping secrets.

"Yes," Garshaw said, nodding at O'Neill. "But maybe in a location more suited to such talks?" She turned her head to look at the Stargate. "Since you are already aware of one of our bases' locations, visiting that planet would not endanger it further."

Catra narrowed her eyes a little. That could be a trap. Unlikely, but not impossible. And without magic, Glimmer couldn't use her powers to get them out quickly. On the other hand, the Tok'ra had no idea about Adora's power. And Catra didn't think a bunch of guerilla fighters and saboteurs would try to start a war with yet another power for any sane reason. And if they weren't sane and cautious, they wouldn't have lasted for so long against the Goa'uld Empire.

O'Neill must have come to the same conclusion since he nodded. "Sounds good to me."

Adora and Glimmer were, of course, all for it. "Yes," Adora said, smiling widely while Glimmer nodded.

And so, after informing Stargate Command, they went through the gate and found themselves in…

…a desert.

"You people really must love sand," Catra said with a deep frown. She didn't like sand. Not at all. The stuff got everywhere, including your clothes and fur. And walking on it was… Well, it wasn't hot enough to burn her feet, at least, but it wasn't comfortable either. Marching on soft sand was far more

exhausting than marching on decent ground. It also reminded her of the Crimson Waste, and those were memories she wasn't very fond of. For a variety of reasons.

Garshaw raised her eyebrows at her. "We don't love sand. But we are used to the environment. We would rather live on a world like this, safe from the Goa'uld, than on a more hospitable one known to the System Lords."

"You could have moved to a more temperate area, though," Entrapta pointed out. "Or is the planet covered by deserts? Is this the temperate part, and the other regions are even worse - so hot, you can't survive without special environmental suits?"

"Having the gate in this location discourages visitors, reducing the danger of being found and of anyone taking more than a passing interest in the world," Garshaw explained.

"And," Jakar added, "if the gate were moved, anyone familiar with the original location would realise that someone had moved it - and they would investigate."

"So, how far do we have to travel until we're at your base?" Catra asked. It couldn't be too far, she thought - Garshaw hadn't taken that long to fetch Martouf. Though they probably had used a skiff or something similar - she couldn't see any road or tracks in the sand, and they had to have a way to haul supplies to and from their base.

"Not too far," Garshaw replied, pulling out a round radio or communicator - Catra didn't recognise the exact model. "We've arrived with guests and need a transport."

Catra narrowed her eyes - and not just because of the sun - and cocked her head, her ears twitching. Was that a whining noise? Yes, it was. She turned to look in that direction. A single vehicle, probably.

Yes, she added to herself as it crested the dune there, it looks like a sort of skiff. Just without the sail. General-purpose light

hovertransport, she'd call it. Pants in any fight since she couldn't see any armour or emitters for shields - just like a skiff, in other words. But it probably could fly over water, not that there was any water in the desert.

"George Lucas has to answer a few questions," she heard O'Neill comment.

"It is not too similar to a skiff, I believe," Teal'c said.

"Form often follows function," Daniel added. "So, it stands to reason that different designs would still show general similarities."

"You use similar transports?" Anise asked.

"Yes," Catra told her. No need to go into details.

"It serves well enough, though maintenance can be difficult at times," Anise said. Judging by her expression, she had done such work before.

"Oh?" Entrapta stared at the approaching vehicle. "Is it the sand? Or do you have to craft all spare parts by hand? Some of the old bots I restored were like that."

"Both," Anise replied.

"Come," Garshaw said. "Let's be off."

They boarded the transport, and the driver let it hover over the gate area, then pushed a button, blasting the sand below with air and erasing their tracks.

"Smooth," Catra said with a grin.

"We have been doing this for some time," Jakar told her with a matching smile as they took off.

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P34-353J, December 4th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill suppressed a frown when the skiff - which did look a bit too much like it came out of Star Wars for his taste - stopped in the middle of the desert between two dunes. There was nothing to distinguish this spot from any other spot of sand.

"We're here," Garshaw said.

"Home sweet home, as you would say," the damn snake spy added with a smile.

Jack wondered where Jakar had picked up that piece of Earth slang. Or idiom, as Daniel would say. He would have to ensure that the man hadn't had access to Earth media while in the mountain - that would have been a massive breach of security. Well, that was something to do once they were back home. He made a point to look around. "Are you sure you don't love sand? Because there's a lot of sand here."

Jakar laughed. "This is merely the entrance." He climbed over the railing and jumped down into the sand without apparent effort. Jack almost expected him to strike a pose as if he were at a gymnastics competition.

Well, two could play that game - especially since Adora had healed Jack. He gripped the railing with both hands and vaulted over it, landing next to the snake spy, and grinned.

Then Catra jumped over the skiff's railing, did a somersault in midair and landed a few yards away with a shit-eating grin.

"Catra!" Adora, followed by the others, didn't show off and simply dropped down from the skiff.

"What? I thought it was a competition. A traditional ritual before guests were admitted into their homes!" Catra's shit-eating grin didn't waver.

"You've been talking too much to Daniel," Jack told her in a flat voice.

“What? We didn’t!” his friend protested. “Well, not recently, at least. And I never mentioned anything like... Oh.” He blinked, then pouted.

Then sand was thrown into the air when Emily landed on it, her legs sinking a foot or two into the soft ground. Entrapta, sitting on top of the bot and somehow having managed not to get thrown off - she’d probably cheated with her hair - cheered.

“This might be a bit much for one transport,” Anise said, looking around. “The robot will have to follow with the next.”

Transport? Were they switching… Ah. “A ring transporter?” Jack asked, cocking his head. “We’re getting the VIP treatment, I see.” And it meant they wouldn’t be able to easily find an entrance.

“Yes. It leaves no tracks,” Garshaw said, pulling her round communicator thingie out again.

“And the skiff continues to another base which serves as a last-ditch decoy?” Catra asked. “Or is this the decoy base?”

Garshaw didn’t answer. Instead, she spoke into the small ball. “We’re here.”

“Should have said ‘a dozen to beam down, Scotty’,” Jack joked.

“Colonel!” Carter hissed next to him.

But he was watching the snakes. None of them showed a reaction other than mild confusion - even the spy. So, Jakar might not have had access to Earth media in depth - or that was what the spy wanted you to think, of course.

Jack didn’t like spooks. He liked alien spooks even less.

Then the familiar rings rose around the group, and, a moment later, they appeared in a room - and were facing half a dozen guards.

But the snakes hadn't drawn their weapons, and Garshaw nodded at the apparent leader. "There is a robot to transport down as well," she told them before turning to address SG-1 and the Etherians. "Please follow us to your quarters. It will take a little while to convene the High Council to meet with you."

They stepped out of the transporter area, and Jack turned to Jakar, tilting his head slightly to the right. "Guest quarters?"

The spy laughed again. "Oh, don't worry - it's not a euphemism for cells. You have free access to explore this base if you do not wish to wait in quite comfortable surroundings."

Jack's eyebrows rose. Full access to their base? Either the Tok'ra weren't as competent as they had to be to survive for so long, or this was a decoy base.

"Thank you," Glimmer spoke up with one of her regal, polite smiles. "It will be nice to freshen up a bit."

Garshaw nodded. "You are our guests. Jakar, please show them their quarters. I will call the rest of the High Council."

"Can we see your lab?" Entrapta asked Anise with a wide smile as Emily appeared behind them. "We're building a new lab, Sam and I, and I'd love to see how other scientists work!"

"Ah…" Anise grimaced. "I don't have a lab in this base," she said.

So, this was a decoy base. Jack grinned. If Entrapta had done this intentionally, he'd tell her well done in private.

"Aw." Entrapta pouted. "Did you have to move your lab for security reasons too?"

"In a manner of speaking, yes." Anise had apparently recovered from her slip.

"Is it in space? Though that would require a guard fleet to keep it safe. Do you have enough naval assets for that? Of course, a

spacelab seems the safest option for a lot of experiments. Or… with your transporters, could you build a lab deep in the bedrock, completely isolated from everyone? But the transporter might still be a risk for spreading biological agents in an accident, and if it failed, you'd be stuck there or outside the lab!"

Jack couldn't tell if Entrapta was more worried about being stuck inside or outside her lab. He guessed the latter.

Then he tried to tune the tech talk out and focus on the base they were travelling through. The tunnels were roomy, but, for all their alien-ness, they looked a bit… rough. And those crystals everywhere… He narrowed his eyes, then grinned. He wasn't an expert on alien technology, but they had two of them with him. Three, actually; he kept forgetting that Bow was a Techmaster because compared to the mad scientist princess, the boy tended to escape notice.

So Jack turned his head and beamed at Entrapta, Carter and Bow. "Hey - did you see those crystals? Have you ever seen similar things?"

Entrapta perked up, skipping over to the closest crystal row. "Oh! How interesting!" Her hair brushed over them. "I don't think I've seen them before."

"Neither have I", Carter said. She touched them and took a look at the wall next to it. After knocking on it, she frowned. "This sounds odd."

"Oh!" Entrapta pulled her tool thingie out, then blinked and turned to face Anise. "Oh! I almost forgot: Can we scan the wall?"

"Ah, yes," Anise replied, her eyes fixed on the tool. "If I can take a look at your scanner."

"Deal!"

Jack suppressed a grimace. That wasn't what he had wanted. And Jakar was smiling as if he knew that.

The damn snake spy probably did, damn him.

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The Tok’Ra Part 2

P34-353J, December 4th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Things were going well. At least Adora thought so. They had made contact with the Tok’ra, proving that Jakar had told them the truth, the Tok’ra had invited them to their base and were preparing to talk about an alliance. She frowned - well, they hadn’t said so outright, actually. But they also hadn’t denied it. So, it was implied, at least. And they had prepared guest quarters for Adora and her friends. Even more importantly, they weren’t under guard. That was a sign of trust, in Adora’s opinion.

Not that they had reached the guest quarters yet - Entrapta and Sam were examining the tunnels here. Quite thoroughly. Both had their scanners out. Well, their personal ones, though Adora had a feeling that Emily was also using hers, and Emily’s scanner was a copy of the magically-enhanced scanner the two had built.

“Oh, look at the molecular structure here!”

“Yes. They are aligned… almost as if they were…”

“Yes, exactly! Emily, check the crystals again!”

Emily beeped.

“Oh, look at that!” Entrapta held her tool out to Sam - presumably to show the results of that scan.

“Definitely a connection to the crystals - the patterns complement each other.”

Adora winced. Her friends were being a little rude. More than a little, in her opinion.

“Your scanners can analyse the molecular structure in that detail?”

“Yes. Look? That’s the crystal’s pattern. And that’s the wall’s!”

Well, at least Anise didn't seem to mind - though that was probably because the Tok'ra scientist was fascinated by Entrapta and Sam's technology.

Adora glanced at Jakar. The agent looked amused. So, they weren't insulting their hosts without meaning to - a danger, as Daniel had stressed, that was always present when making first contact. He had a number of stories to show that, too.

"Oh, I see! The crystals have been… altering the stone. The density is much higher than further away, but it's not high enough to account for the entire volume we're standing in."

And now Bow was getting into it. Adora softly sighed. If things continued like this, they wouldn't reach their guest quarters before the Tok'ra High Council was ready for them.

"And what does it mean? For non-scientists?" Catra asked suddenly, interrupting the others. She had her head cocked to the side and a bored expression - but Adora could tell that it was fake. Just like in cadet training when she had been fooling other squads. And instructors sometimes.

"Oh… isn't it obvious?" Entrapta asked, looking surprised.

Adora shook her head, as did Glimmer and Catra.

"Oh! Wellll… the tunnel here was created completely artificially."

"And that's never the case with tunnels, right?" Jack must be a little tense as well - he was usually a bit less sarcastic when talking to Entrapta.

"Well, technically…"

"They were created very quickly using the crystals to form and mould the stone, sir," Sam explained. "Judging by the readins we took, the stone's structure is still adjusting - cooling down where it had been compressed so much, the molecules heated up."

“Yes! But not the whole mass was compressed - a big part isn’t here. So, either it was used as fuel - converted into energy in a non-explosive way - or it was disintegrated,” Entrapta added.

“We didn’t find any traces of loose molecules in the environment, though,” Bow said.

Adora blinked. Did that mean…

“You made the whole base to meet us, didn’t you?” Jack said.

Anise looked surprised, but Jakar smiled. “Indeed, Colonel O’Neill. Quite perceptive.”

“I have my moments,” Jack replied.

Adora glanced at Catra. Her lover didn’t look surprised. Which didn’t surprise Adora. Catra was much better at the sneaky stuff than her.

“Yes,” Anise confirmed. “We can rapidly grow tunnels using our technology.”

Catra whistled, then grinned at Adora. “Imagine what we could’ve done with that in the war.”

Oh. Oh, yes. Adora could imagine that. Very well. If they had this technology… they could assault any bunker from any side they wanted. They could create safe and hidden supply lines. Entire bases could be fabricated in no time, out of sight of the enemy.

She glanced at Glimmer. They needed this alliance more than they had expected.

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This was fascinating! The Tok’ra could *grow* tunnels. Samantha Carter had thought, at first, that they used advanced technology to rapidly drill tunnels - probably by using a way to disrupt the molecular bonds to facilitate excavating the material - but it was

so much more. Their technology - she still hadn't found out how the crystals did this - shaped the stone. And used part of it to fuel the process. Probably not a self-sustaining reaction, though - at least, she hoped not. If such a thing ever went out of control, it might actually manage something close to the - impossible as far as Sam knew - Grey Goo scenario. Not that she had any idea how a self-sustaining partial disintegration process might work, either.

"So, the crystals are the key. That means they must be used to project a field that changes the matter," Entrapta said.

"Yes." Anise nodded after a moment's hesitation. Then she cocked her head. "And your scanner is a very advanced multi-frequency device. However, that wouldn't result in some of the readings I see here. So… how are you doing this? It must be this crystal here." She tapped part of the externally-visible crystal array that boosted the scanner with magic.

"Yes, that's the key part of the scanner," Entrapta confirmed. "It bypasses the limits of the standard scanner. Some of the limits, at least - we still have trouble with the finer details at longer ranges, and its range itself is still limited, though planetary scans are reliably possible, and some effects do reduce the scanner's effectiveness. But we're working on that!"

If not as often as we probably should, Sam thought as she nodded in agreement. But there was so much else to do… and so few who could assist, much less take over some projects. Years of secrecy meant even geniuses like Hawking had to first catch up before they could contribute to the field.

Which, Sam admitted to herself while she ran another scan, had some good side as well - some of those geniuses could do with a little humbling. At least in her opinion. While none had said so to her face, she knew that some of them looked down on her for being a woman, a soldier, or both. Iwan never did that. Or, she couldn't help adding, in the Colonel's voice, he was too well-trained to let it slip.

“Oh, look at that!” Entrapta interrupted her thoughts. “That trace here… the structures are half-formed.”

“Yes.” Sam narrowed her eyes. That was the first trace of a denser but not quite fully formed area they had seen. And that meant they could deduce something about how the process worked. After extensive modelling and more scanning, and probably not enough to understand, much less replicate the process, but it was a start.

“This is remarkable. You aren’t just enhancing the scan with a different sensor - you’re enhancing the scan itself! This is… Not even supercharging a scanner with Naquadah would achieve that.”

Supercharging a scanner with Naquadah? Sam blinked. That would…

“If you empower the scan and have Naquadah present…” Entrapta frowned.

“...it could destabilise the entire array,” Sam finished for her friend. “Violently and exothermically.”

“Boom!” Entrapta mimed an explosion.

Anise frowned. Either she didn’t like the miming or… “Yes, it can lead to remarkable explosions if mishandled,” the Tok’ra said.

She was speaking from experience, Sam was sure. But she wouldn’t ask - it was clear that Anise didn’t like to be reminded of such a failure.

“Oh! Did that happen to you? Did you lose your entire lab? That happened to me once. Well, more than once, but only once through a completely unexpected explosion instead of an unexpectedly powerful explosion,” Entrapta said, beaming at Anise.

“Something like that, yes,” Ansie said with a wince.

Entrapta nodded. “Well, you can make a new lab easily with this technology, though the tools might be a bother to replace - although that means it’s also an opportunity to upgrade!”

“Especially your safety procedures,” Bow cut in with a forced smile.

Anise didn’t look very impressed. She nodded, quite curtly. “Yes. However… the way your scanner works, you either have it slaved to a much more powerful array somewhere else, close enough to work…” She glanced at Emily. “But the signals would be detected. Or you have added another element. And those crystals…” She gasped. “It can’t be!” Her eyes widened as she looked at Entrapta. “Magic?”

Sam hesitated just long enough - should she lie or not? It would come out sooner or later anyway; Adora would ask to return magic to the planet - for Entrapta to nod. “Exactly! It’s a magic scanner.”

“But… magic stopped working long ago,” Anise said.

“We’re bringing it back!” Entrapta beamed at her. “Technically, it never stopped working - you, that means, the galaxy, simply lost access to it. Did you work with magic before it was taken away?”

“Taken away? The common theory amongst System Lords is that magic was the work of the Ancients and that whatever system had powered it had finally broken down a thousand years ago,” Anise said. “You mean that was a deliberate action?”

“Yes. Although technically, it was done by the Ancients, I guess,” Entrapta said. “Do you remember it?”

Anise shook her head. “No. I wasn’t born back then. And I never worked with magic - our species has no talent for it.”

“But shouldn’t you have genetic memories of your progenitor?” Entrapta blinked.

Sam narrowed her eyes. Indeed, a Goa'uld or Tok'ra should remember the time when magic worked. And Goa'uld couldn't do magic? Not even with talented hosts? Something to confirm.

The Colonel interrupted by yawning. "Say, can we get to those guest quarters? My back's killing me."

Right. Sam refused to blush even though she just realised that they had been holding up everyone else. But it was such a fascinating technology…

At least Anise and Bow looked as sheepish as Sam felt. Entrapta, of course, wasn't fazed. "Aw. This is so interesting… although I guess we can continue with the walls in the guest quarters! Let's go, Emily!"

Sam could tell that the Colonel wasn't pleased about that, but he should have known better than to expect Entrapta to stop examining such fascinating new technology.

"So, Bow, getting distracted by the shiny new technology? Should Glimmer get jealous?" Sam heard Catra ask as they started to follow Jakar.

Although, Sam suddenly realised as Catra and Adora teased Bow, with Glimmer joining in for a mock-disappointed complaint that had the man flounder for a moment, the Tok'ra agent couldn't have known the base beforehand. Nor could have Anise - both had been away when the base had been built. So, if they could serve as guides, then this base must have a pre-set layout or there were markers indicating where which part was. Since she hadn't noticed any such markers, she was betting on the former. But she'd have to check with the others about this - she could have missed something, after all.

"Here!" Jakar announced with a bow that seemed just a bit too intricate to be genuine or completely serious, and next to him, a sliding door opened. Big enough to let Emily pass through.

“Neat! Can you grow such a mechanism as well?” Entrapta asked, bending over to examine the door.

That was a good question. If this technology wasn’t limited to growing tunnels and rooms but could be used to grow furniture and more complex things…

“Standard packages can be easily installed,” Anise said, which was a little evasive, in Sam’s opinion. “But come inside.”

The guest quarters looked spartan compared to quarters a state visit could expect in most countries on Earth, much less the lavish luxury of Bright Moon, but for a group in hiding, they were quite generous, in Sam’s opinion. The furniture mostly but not completely matched, so that might indicate that the Tok’ra couldn’t grow more than tunnels. Well, they could ask Anise.

*****

“Nice digs,” Catra commented as she looked around. “Quite a step up from Horde barracks.”

“Catra!” Adora hissed under her breath.

“What? It’s true. It’s a compliment,” Catra said. “This is their equivalent of generic construction.” And as bland as a guest room on Earth - in Bright Moon, someone would have added little touches to make the guest feel more at home. Or feel more out of their depth if the guest had been raised in the Horde, Catra added mentally with a snort.

“We’re guests here!” Adora insisted.

Yes, they were. But since they didn’t have privacy - not that Catra expected the room to be private even if the two Tok’ra had left; in the Tok’ra’s place, she would have crammed it full of surveillance - she felt justified in ribbing their hosts a bit.

Or trying to rib them - Anise was busy examining Entrapta’s technology while Entrapta and the others were examining the

walls of the room, and Jakar looked perfectly at ease. The spy really was too smooth. And too friendly. Not as bad as Double Trouble - Catra didn't have the urge to claw his face off every time he smiled - but he got her hackles raised.

"We do our best, but our means are limited - we do wage war against an Empire that has us outnumbered many, many times over, forcing us to remain in hiding and be prepared to move at the shortest notice."

"That's terrible!" Adora said. "How often do you have to move?"

"Often enough to keep us from setting down roots anywhere, I'd say," he replied with a shrug, "but not enough to force us to constantly move."

Another non-answer. Catra suppressed a theatrical sigh. "So, do your decoy bases see regular use against the Goa'uld?" She sat down on one of the couches - or were they supposed to be beds? They were not as soft as Bright Moon's 'swallowing pillows' but softer than a normal couch. "Since you don't have a Stargate in the base, you would have to outwait any attackers before you could leave. Letting them destroy a base would probably speed that up." And keep them from just blowing up the planet if they couldn't find the Tok'ra but knew that they were present.

"They have been used in that capacity in the past, yes," Jakar admitted. "Mostly to fool the Goa'uld into thinking that we already moved before they arrived." He smiled wryly. "Which is why Garshaw will not be happy to hear that you have realised our building capability and will oppose sharing this technology - if the Goa'uld suspect we can do this, they will be much harder to fool with fake bases."

Entrapta wouldn't be happy to hear that, Catra knew. She glanced at the corner, where Entrapta, Bow and the others were still examining the stone wall. It seemed she hadn't overheard them.

“You won’t have to fool them any more if you join us,” Adora said. “We can match them in open warfare. Not that we are planning to strike openly from the start, of course - the element of surprise has tobe preserved as long as possible.”

“I sincerely hope so,” Jakar told her. “But I am not on the High Council. You will have to convince them to change our ways. My own voice will not move them much, especially since I am still a little suspect after enjoying your hospitality.”

So, they thought he was compromised? Catra narrowed her eyes.

But Jack spoke before she could. “Why don’t they trust you? You’ve got all that genetic memory and a thousand years of working together.”

Jakar, for once not smiling so smugly or overly friendly, shook his head. “Unlike the Goa’uld, we do not extend our lives with sarcophaguses. So, while we share the memories of our distant ancestors, we do not live for thousands of years. Our life spans are more comparable to yours.”

Oh. Catra glanced at the others. That changed a few things.

*****

So the snakes were as mortal as humans. That was crucial intel, Jack O’Neill knew - their calculations had been based on the assumption that they were dealing with aliens who had been alive for a thousand years or more. And who probably counted on being alive for another few thousand years. Then again, they had that genetic memory…

“Really?” Of course, Daniel would jump on that.

Jack was almost relieved - Daniel being quiet while meeting new aliens was very uncharacteristic. Almost. Daniel was just a little bit better at talking himself out of trouble than he was at getting in trouble.

And there he went. “But you still have the genetic memory of your ancestors - all of them, I suppose?”

Jakar’s smile turned a bit blander, Jack noted. “That’s a very personal question, Dr Jackson.”

“Oh, I am sorry - it’s just that we have, although not nearly enough, quite the amount of information about Goa’uld society, so we know that the fact that its members, especially its leaders, were so extremely long-lived, was crucial in shaping it. Although this is merely an assumption, and a generalisation, and based on human behaviour, older people tend to be more conservative, and that would explain the relative stagnation of Goa’uld society.” And there came his charming smile. “So, the existence of a society of, well, people who share the same biology, but have a very different lifespan, provides a fascinating counterpart to check such assumptions.” He blinked. “I mean, that sounds… I didn’t mean it like an experiment. But I would love to learn more about your society.”

Jack nodded in agreement, if not for the same reasons as Daniel. They needed to know more about the Tok’ra - as much as possible. Not just for the upcoming negotiations but for the future as well. Whether they managed to form an alliance or not, the Tok’ra were extremely dangerous.

Jakar’s smile remained polite as he tilted his head a smidge to the side. “Half of our society is formed by humans, Dr Jackson.” Then his voice switched. “Yes. I fear that you might be operating from a mistaken assumption. The Tok’ra aren’t like the Goa’uld - we are their partners, not their slaves.”

Daniel blinked. “Of course.” He bowed his head. “I didn’t want to give offence. Obviously, the comparatively reduced lifespan of the symbiont would affect their relationship with the hosts as well. The power imbalance between a being who has lived for thousands of years and a human would render any relationship less than equal no matter the intentions of everyone involved, but if that factor is gone…” He frowned in his half-pouty way. “There’s

still the genetic memory to consider, of course. As I said, fascinating."

Great. Jack glanced at the corner where Carter was still geeking out about snake science. He was in danger of losing half of his team to the snakes! He bit down on the first comment that came to mind - neither of his friends would have taken it well - and joked: "Careful with that enthusiasm, Danny, or they'll end up offering you a symbiont."

Daniel glared at him. "Jack!"

Jack's chuckle died, though, when he saw Jakar's reaction.

Jakar switched back to his snake voice. "Actually, Colonel O'Neill, we're always looking for willing hosts. I can guarantee that this will come up in negotiations."

Oh, no! Hell, no! Jack wouldn't let anyone of his team get snaked! Or anyone else, if he could help it!

*****

Jack looked like he had bitten into a brown Horde ration bar that had gone bad. Or, Adora added in her mind, one that had been disguised as a grey one and gone bad.

"Oh? Do you have trouble finding willing hosts?" Daniel asked, cocking his head.

"It's not always easy to find a human who can make an informed decision," Jakar explained. "Consent is meaningless if it's based on wrong information or on indoctrination. And with the Goa'uld keeping their human slaves ignorant and teach them to worship their masters as gods…" He shrugged, and his voice changed again. This was Mats talking, now. "It took a long time for me to truly understand what joining with Jakar would mean. I was raised as a slave, to faithfully worship a false god, and to overcome that…" He shook his head. "We have to be sure that

there will be no false expectations which could lead to resentment afterwards."

Daniel looked impressed. "I see. Of course, recruiting from a Goa'uld slave society, or less technologically advanced civilisations like the Cimmerians, would pose such problems."

"And we cannot just kidnap people to teach them the truth. The more they learn, the greater the risk they would pose, should the Goa'uld get ahold of them, which means we couldn't allow them to return even if they rejected our offer to become a host," Jakar, back in charge of the body, explained.

"And you would have to educate them as well so they can function in your society, which is obviously more technologically advanced than the typical Goa'uld slave society. You cannot be an equal partner in a relationship if you depend on your symbiont for everything." Daniel nodded. "If Sha're had come to Earth with me, instead of us staying on Abydos, where she could teach me about daily life, I wonder how we would have fared…" He trailed off, a pained expression on his face.

Adora bit her lower lip. She felt for her friend - she knew what he was going through. Better than almost anyone else, she added with a glance at Catra, remembering when her lover had been controlled by Horde Prime. But they would rescue Sha're and remove the Goa'uld possessing her. Reunite Daniel with his love. She was She-Ra; saving people was her duty.

"We'll save her," Jack echoed Adora's thoughts.

She nodded in agreement. "Yes," she said as confidently as she could. "We will."

Jakar cocked his head, frowning a little. "Your partner was taken by the Goa'uld?"

Daniel nodded. "Not just taken. Taken as a host," he spat through clenched teeth - quite an unusual tone and expression for him, Adora thought.

“And you wish our help to remove the Goa’uld from her.”

So, they could do it! That was part of the reason they were here. They could save Lieutenant Lenkova first, then! Adora smiled.

As did Daniel. “You can do it?”

“We can remove a Goa’uld from their host, yes,” Jakar confirmed.

“Without killing the host, I hope,” Jack cut in.

“Of course.” Jakar narrowed his eyes at him, Adora noted.

“Just checking,” Jack replied with a slightly toothy smile. “Wouldn’t want to find out too late about side effects.”

“We aren’t Goa’uld, Colonel O’Neill. We do not consider people expendable.”

“You blew up a lab with all the prisoners still inside,” Jack shot back.

Jakar met Jack’s eyes. “As I explained, as far as I knew at the time, I could not save them without failing my mission, and allowing Apophis to develop biological weapons would have doomed far more people. I did not make this decision lightly, Colonel, but I would make it again. We are compassionate, but not foolishly so. We are fighting a war.”

Adora pressed her lips together. That was… well, he wasn’t wrong, but if Adora had been there, they could have saved everyone. They couldn’t give up hope lightly when it came to saving people.

Catra, though, nodded. “Yes. You made the call, and while it was a bad one, you didn’t know any better. If we had been informed, things would have gone differently.”

Jakar frowned - did he expect them not to point that out? - but slowly nodded as well.

In the sudden silence, they could hear Entrapta point out something about their scanner to Anise that Adora heard but didn't understand. She glanced at Glimmer, who seemed to follow the conversation. As a trained sorceress, she knew more about magic than Adora. And also about magitech. Maybe Adora should study magic as well…

"So, how long do Tok'ra live?" Catra asked, breaking the silence.

"Barring an unfortunately not quite rare death at the hands of the Goa'uld or their servants," Jakar said with a glance at Teal'c, "we can live for several centuries."

He had hesitated a moment before answering, Adora realised. And that was a bit vague, still.

Jack whistled. "Several centuries?"

"Oh. That's… quite long compared to the average human lifespan," Daniel commented. "What about your hosts?"

"They share our longevity. It would hardly be a true partnership if they died long before our time," Jakar commented.

His voice changed, and Mats said: "Indeed. Which is another reason finding hosts can be difficult. To see your family, maybe your children, grow old and die while you stay young is not something everyone can stand. If you have a family left, of course."

"Yes," Jack commented. He looked like he wanted to say more but kept his lips pressed closed instead, looking rather grim.

He must be thinking of his dead son, Adora realised, and had to refrain from trying to console him. Jack wouldn't appreciate her hugging him or squeezing his shoulder. Even if he really needed it, in her opinion.

And they weren't in private, anyway.

“You know, you’ve been telling us a lot about what the Tok’ra want and would expect,” Catra spoke up again, tilting her head as she looked at Jakar. “And right before our negotiations with you.” She flashed her fangs at him. “Mighty generous of you.”

“I believe that the more you know about us and understand our situation, the easier you will find common ground, “Jakar, back in control, replied. “Both of our people need this alliance, and to see it fail because of misunderstandings and ignorance would be unacceptable.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded.

“Laudable,” Glimmer said. “But will your friends understand?” She glanced at Anise, who was, at least as far as Adora could tell, still captivated by the magitech scanner.

Jakar shrugged. “I do what is necessary even if it costs me.”

“Even when it means going against your friends?” Jack asked.

“I would not betray them, but I won’t blindly follow a course of action I consider foolish either.” Jakar shrugged. “Blind obedience is what Goa’uld expect and demand.” Once again, he glanced at Teal’c.

“Indeed.”

“You don’t like Jaffa, do you?” Catra asked.

“They do most of the System Lords’ killing,” Jakar replied. “It is hard to... not see them as the willing tool of our enemy. Too much blood has been spilt at their eager hands.”

Oh. “But Teal’c turned away from that,” Adora said - Catra was looking grim as well, she noticed. “Once he had the opportunity.”

“He may be an exception. But how many of your prisoners turned against Apophis?” Jakar asked.

“Everyone can change,” Adora told him. “Sometimes, all they need is the chance to do so.”

“And sometimes, it’s not enough,” Catra muttered next to her.

Adora wrapped her arm around her lover’s shoulder, pulling her against her side despite her squeaking protest. Catra had changed. Adora knew that even if Catra sometimes forgot. “We know about being raised in ignorance and sent to fight for evil rulers,” she told Jakar.

His eyebrows rose. “I see.”

“Yeah, I think you do,” Jack cut in. “To avoid mistakes and ignorance, improve understanding yadda, yadda.”

Jakar slowly nodded with a faint smile.

Ah.

Jakar was a spy, Adora reminded herself. And information flowed both ways.

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“I see. So, this is the converter that powers the magic part of the scanner. Ingenious. And with that, you can use magitech.” Anise hadn’t taken her eyes off the scanner since Entrapta had opened it. Not that Samantha Carter would have expected anything else - the Tok’ra scientist had been very enthusiastic since they’d met. And very quick to understand their explanations.

They hadn’t gone into too much detail, of course - that would have been sharing technology, and Anise hadn’t exactly shared blueprints of their tunnel growing technology either, but Sam felt that this needed some clarification. “You can use existing magitech, yes - but to construct a new magitech component, you need to work in a magically active environment.”

“A planet where magic has been returned,” Entrapta added. “There aren’t many of those around yet.”

“A planet like yours?” Anise asked, cocking her head in a way that looked just a bit weird - alien - to Sam even though part of her, no, the remnants of Jolinar, found it perfectly normal.

“Yes. Etheria never lost its magic, and Earth has had its magic restored.” Entrapta smiled. “We’re planning to restore magic to the galaxy, but it’s going a little slow because of all the security concerns.”

“You can restore magic to a planet?” Anise looked… Well, Sam hoped she never looked like that when faced with exciting new technology. The teasing the Colonel could come up with about wanting to marry a computer…

“Not me,” Entrapta said.

“It’s not a technological problem,” Sam cut her friend off before she could mention Adora’s name. “I am sure it will come up at the negotiations,” she added, with a glance at Entrapta.

“Right!” Entrapta nodded, her hair bopping a little as it held the scanner. “Some people tend to be a little nervous about possible side effects, even though it’s perfectly safe - generally.”

“That shouldn’t be a problem,” Anise said. “The potential of magitech outweighs any possible danger magic could pose. Although I remember reading that magic was limited to those people who had a particular talent for it…”

“Yes. And they need training as well to do magic,” Entrapta said. “But anyone can work with magical components. That’s just science. And some magitech allows you to refine or effectively create magical components.”

That, once again, was just a little too much information. “So, it’s not as if restoring magic will turn a planet into a magitech

factory," Sam said. "But, again, such details are best left to the negotiations."

Anise nodded. "Of course. They're bound to be interesting. And speaking of the upcoming negotiations… I think I need to talk to Garshaw and the others before those start." She looked at the scanner again, shaking her head, then turned away with obvious reluctance.

Sam knew the feeling.

"Jakar," Anise said. "We should let our guests rest before the negotiations."

"Ah, of course." Jakar bowed to the Colonel and the others. "We'll take our leave then."

"You do that," the Colonel replied, smiling until the doors closed behind the two Tok'ra. Then he sighed and turned to Sam and Entrapta. "So… where are the cameras I should wave to?"

"Huh?" Entratpa looked confused.

"We haven't scanned for surveillance devices yet," Sam replied. Not with Anise watching them.

"Well, let's do it. I guess they already know all about your fancy scanner anyway." He tilted his head a bit towards her, Sam saw.

She pressed her lips together at the rebuke. Yes, she should have kept Entrapta from spilling more intel, but… This was a diplomatic meeting. As Adora had said, trust required trust, and someone had to make the first step.

Though they might have taken a few steps too far, should negotiations fail. On the other hand, they had gotten detailed scans of the crystal used by the Tok'ra. Enough to have at least some idea about how it worked. Emily's scans should be even more detailed as well - and they hadn't revealed that to Anise. Although she probably suspected.

But first, they had to scan for surveillance devices. Or security devices, depending on your point of view.

“Found it! Them!” Entrapta announced thirty seconds later, hair pointing at two corners of the room.

“Two cameras and microphones,” Sam added, looking at the readout. She looked at the Colonel, raising her eyebrows.

“Let’s get some privacy without destroying our new friends’ tools,” he replied.

“Yes, that would be rude,” Glimmer agreed, if with a touch of sarcasm.

Sam nodded and triggered a noise-cancelling field. They’d have to avoid letting the cameras see their faces to protect against lip-reading, but that wasn’t too hard now that they knew where the cameras were. “Done, sir,” she announced.

“Those are rather standard devices - for Goa’uld,” Entrapta added with a pout. “I would have expected better technology from people spying on the Goa’uld.”

“They probably didn’t use their best technology here,” Catra said.

“Then why install it at all?” Entrapta shook her head.

“Habit?” Catra shrugged. “They’re spies, after all.”

“It might be merely standard practice,” Daniel pointed out. “Something everyone expects.”

“Whatever,” the Colonel spoke up. “They know that we know that they know. Let’s talk diplomacy. And secrecy.”

Sam winced a little at the glance he sent her.

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O’Neill wasn’t happy with Sam and Entrapta, Catra could easily tell. And, well, he had his reasons - the two had spilt some intel to the Tok’ra; Catra had followed their conversation with Anise quite closely. There hadn’t been anything too important, and they had gotten some intel back, but still, it could’ve gone better - although it could’ve gone worse as well. And Entrapta was Entrapta. She wasn’t a spy or professional soldier. If you wanted or needed her talents, you had to make some allowances for her quirks.

And she was Catra’s friend.

So when O’Neill started talking about not revealing secrets, Catra shrugged pointedly and interrupted him. “Trying to keep things secret that will come out anyway if we form an alliance is stupid.”

“It also weakens our negotiation position,” O’Neill retorted, frowning at her rather than at Entrapta. “The more they know about us, the better they can make demands. They can’t ask for something they don’t know.”

Catra was about to answer, but Glimmer was faster. “That’s short-sighted, Jack. We’re here to get an ally we can trust, and we won’t get that if we play games with them.” She shook her head. “This isn’t a competition.”

“We’re not going to play games. But they’re not telling us everything, and you can bet that they want the best deal for themselves.” He snorted. “Jakar’s good at playing the helpful friend, but he’s a spy - and he really wants this alliance.”

“The best deal for everyone is an alliance with trusted friends,” Adora said, nodding firmly.

Catra suppressed a sigh - and a sappy smile. That was… well, so like Adora. And her lover wasn’t wrong, of course, but… “Yeah, but not everyone wants to be your friend, even if they act like it.” She tried not to wince at Aora’s frown.

“Exactly!” O`Neill said with a sharp nod.

“But we didn’t do that,” Sam spoke up. “We discussed fairly obvious technology, not anything crucial.”

O’Neill frowned some more. “Magic seems quite crucial to me. Healing, scanning, zombifying…”

“Magic is an obvious topic that would have come up during negotiations anyway,” Glimmer said. “This way, they won’t feel as if we tried to trick them or attempted to hide it from them.”

“Not that we have to hide magic from the Tok’ra,” Entrapta said. “Anise was very interested! I don’t think they’ll fear it.”

“That was one Tok’ra. We don’t know what the others will think about it,” Daniel cautioned her. “Especially if they can’t use magic.”

“They can use magitech, though,” Entrapta pointed out.

“That might not appeal to everyone.” Daniel pushed his glasses up with one finger. “And what will they think about magical ways to eject a symbiont from a host, possibly killing the symbiont in the process?”

That was a good point, Catra had to admit. Of course, magic spells and powers could kill anyone, but that was something you were used to on Etheria - especially in the Horde. If the Tok’ra were not used to it, magic might terrify them.

“Jakar didn’t seem to mind, either,” Adora said.

“Jakar has an agenda.” O’Neill shook his head. “He’s been far too helpful to be trusted.”

And he was a spy.

“He told us about the Tok’ra’s goals and needs,” Adora protested.

“About some of them. And he was slippery at that. ‘Several centuries’? ‘Comparable’? Remember how he dodged the question

about their genetic memory?" Jack scoffed. "He would make a fine politician."

Daniel frowned at him, Catra saw. "That's a very biased view, Jack. It's clear that the relationship between the symbiont and the host is at the core of the Tok'ra society. That's what separates them from the Goa'uld. They go as far as to consider themselves a different species because of this. You don't expect him to tell us everything up front, do you?"

Catra smirked at the way Daniel turned O'Neill's words back at him.

"It's so crucial for them, they will ask for more hosts from us!" O'Neill shot back. "You heard him - they're always looking for hosts!"

But who would want to share their body with a snake that could take control of it anytime they chose? Catra shuddered at the thought.

"Which is an interesting point, Jack," Daniel said. "If a host lives roughly as long as the Tok'ra, and they always need new hosts, then they must have a significant number of Tok'ra without hosts. And that means…"

"They must have a queen," Teal'c said.

Catra shrugged. That seemed obvious to her. "Well, someone has to give birth to all the Tok'ra, right? Especially If they don't live as long as the Goa'uld."

"They didn't mention anything about us meeting their queen," Glimmer said, frowning a little. "Just the High Council."

"Maybe they want to surprise us?" Adora asked.

Catra suppressed a snort.

“I doubt that.” Daniel shook his head. “Their queen would be crucial for their entire civilisation. Should anything happen to her, they would be doomed unless they find a replacement - they would die out. So, they would likely keep her as safe as possible, far from any threat no matter how remote.”

That made sense. “Their biggest secret,” Catra said.

“Indeed,” Teal’c said.

Catra grinned. The upcoming negotiations should be fun.

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The Tok’ra Part 3

P34-353J, December 4th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O’Neill generally liked Catra. She was the one amongst the Etherians - with the possible exception of Hordak, but Jack wasn’t going there - who knew that you couldn’t trust everybody to play straight with you. More importantly, she was the one who knew how you fought a war. She was the last of the Etherians, actually, who Jack would have expected to defend Carter and Entrapta spilling Alliance secrets to the snakes.

But she had just done so, neatly derailing his well-deserved reminder that operational security was a thing in the military for a reason - something Carter knew very well. Usually, it was Daniel whom Jack had to remind of such things, not his fellow officer. Jack refrained from frowning at the thought - the others would pick up on it. But Carter had changed over the last few months. Jack had thought it was because of the Etherians and their antics. He was too old and had seen too much to change, but between She-Ra and her friends’ idealism and the lure of Entrapta’s technology and special enthusiasm for science, even an officer like Carter couldn’t avoid being affected. That it was hard to be mad at Entrapta wasn’t helping, of course - if you criticised her, you felt as if you had just shot Bambi’s mom.

And if Entrapta’s friends noticed, it also made you feel as if you just kicked a landmine. A nuclear landmine in Adora’s case, and a Bouncing Betty in Catra’s case, Jack added to himself while he watched Adora go through everything they knew about the Tok’ra in preparation for the meeting with the High Council.

But there might be more behind this. Jack glanced at Carter, who was still busy going over Emily’s records. What if this wasn’t Carter growing careless because of her friendship with Entrapta but a relic of her possession by the snake? She said she didn’t remember much, but that meant she did remember something.

Was she unconsciously seeing the Tok'ra as trusted friends? Or more?

He buried *that* thought at once. But such… contamination would explain Carter's lapses.

Damn. He had to talk to her. Find out if she was influenced by the snake that had controlled her. But they were in the middle of a mission - and about to face the High Snake Council. The worst moment to try and find out if his Second-in-Command was compromised. Ah, well - he'd been in worse situations.

He clapped his hands together. "So, kids, I hate to interrupt playtime, but we'll soon be facing the High Council and have to be on our best behaviour."

In the corner of his eye, he caught Carter frowning at him, like usual when he was a bit too flippant.

"You're usually the one who has to keep that in mind the most, I think." And Daniel reacted as usual as well. He was dependable like that. Even though he was also, well, not compromised, but not unbiased either - the snakes here could offer him a way to save his wife.

But Jack was taking what he could right now.

"That's why we're studying all our available intel!" Adora said. "To be sure we're as prepared as we can be."

"Or just to calm down our nerves," Catra, sprawled on a couch with a datapad sitting unused on her stomach, added.

"You don't look nervous," Gimmer commented.

"Because I don't have any reason to be nervous," Catra responded. "I'm not a princess; securing an alliance is your job. If anything goes wrong, it won't be my fault. I'm just here to watch. But no pressure!"

“We’re not nervous either,” Glimmer shot back. “We know what we’re doing.”

“I sure hope so.”

Hell, the catwoman is stealing my shtick, Jack thought. Somehow, that made him feel even older right now. “So… don’t get lost in details. Just remember: We want an alliance, but we don’t want to hand them everything for nothing in return. Or almost nothing.” Growing tunnels was nice and all, but Jack had a feeling that this war wouldn’t be decided by tunnels. And probably not on the ground, either - this war would be decided in space. “And yes, honesty is the best policy, but information is valuable. Trust goes both ways. And yes,” he cut off Adora when she opened her mouth, “someone has to take the first step, but we already did that.”

Catra chuckled, Teal’c didn’t comment, but the rest of the group looked slightly annoyed. Well, except for Entrapta, who looked a bit confused.

Before anyone could say anything - probably repeat themselves - they heard a buzzer from the door.

“It’s open! Come in!” Jack yelled before Daniel made it to the door. When the door opened and Jakar entered, Jack made a mental note to remember that the room’s sound insulation wasn’t up to snuff. Another thing to consider and analyse for the geeks and spooks back home.

“The High Council is now ready for you,” the snake told them.

“And it only took them three hours,” Jack commented after a glance at his watch. “I’m impressed.”

Jakar smiled, but Daniel pouted at him. “Jack!”

“No, seriously,” Jack told his friend. “Imagine how long it would have taken - did take - for the US government to react in their place. And the US government isn’t hiding from the Evil Galactic

Empire, snake edition. I'm genuinely impressed." Jack wasn't even lying - the snakes could have made them cool their heels for a day at least. And many would have done so in their place - not at least so they wouldn't appear as if they needed an alliance. Hell, that sort of powerplay was the bread and butter of politicians.

And Jack had a feeling that the snakes here were no exception. But were they actually that hard off for an alliance, or were they playing some game?

They'd soon find out. "Well, let's not make them wait for us! Shall we?" He flashed his teeth at the snake.

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The Tok'ra seem to be quite practical, Adora thought as they entered the meeting room. Instead of some far too-tall and far too-large hall, with oversized tables on a pedestal for the council and pillars lining the walls, it was a decently sized room with two big, crescent-shaped tables facing each other. Of course, the Tok'ra had been fighting a war against the Goa'uld for millennia, so if they weren't practical, they'd probably be dead already.

And they were standing to meet them, Garshaw in the lead. "Welcome," she said, bowing her head. "I am the Grand Councillor, Garshaw of Belote. These are Per'sus, Malinor, Sak'ram, Hen'ru and Salesh. We are the Tok'ra High Council - we speak for every Tok'ra, and we have the authority to form an alliance."

"We greet you, High Council," Glimmer spoke up. "I am Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon. These are She-Ra, Princess of Power, Princess Entrapta of Dryl, Colonel Jack'Neill of Earth, Captain Carter, Techmaster Bow, Dr Daniel Jackson, Teal'c and Catra."

They bowed as well, though Catra smirked as she did so - and Adora couldn't frown at her, not in the middle of the meeting. Or at Jakar leaving.

"I speak for the Princess Alliance, and I am authorised to make treaties in their name, but any treaty involving the Alliance with

Earth has to be negotiated with diplomats from Earth as well," Glimmer explained.

"So we don't have the authority to make a binding treaty," Jack said. "But we can get things squared away."

"Does that mean that we could make an alliance with the Princess Alliance even if negotiations with Earth should fail?" Per'sus asked,

That was a good question, Adora had to admit. And judging by the reactions of SG-1, it looked as if things got a bit complicated.

Glimmer kept smiling, but it was her polite 'political smile', as Adora knew. "In theory, yes. But we're committed to the Alliance and the war against the Goa'uld, and being in two different alliances, unaligned with each other, would not help our aims. We need a coordinated, unified strategy if we want to defeat the Goa'uld with the least casualties on all sides."

"Let's sit down," one of the Tok'ra councillors, Sak'ram, said. "It's clear we have a lot to discuss."

They took their seats, Glimmer sitting opposite Garshaw, with Adora and Jack at her side, next to Catra and Sam, respectively, with Entrapta on Catra's other side, followed by Bow, and Daniel and Teal'c anchoring their right flank.

Adora wanted to frown. She shouldn't be thinking like this - this wasn't a battle; they weren't in formation. This was a meeting with potential allies in the war against the Goa'uld. Future friends.

"So, we're here to conduct exploratory talks. Nothing binding," Garshaw said.

"Yes." Glimmer nodded.

"But before we start going into nitty-gritty details," Per'sus spoke up. "You represent an alliance between several Earth countries and the Etherian alliance, correct?"

“Yes,” Glimmer confirmed. “The Princess Alliance, forged to defend Etheria against the Horde. My parents were amongst the founders and leaders.”

“And you have the power to make binding decisions for your alliance,” Per’sus went on.

“Yes.” Glimmer leaned forward a little. “Between us here, we represent the most powerful kingdom of Etheria, the most technologically advanced kingdom and the most powerful military power of Etheria.”

“And we have the trust of our friends,” Adora added.

To her relief, neither did Catra mutter about *some* of them having the trust of the alliance and nor did Jack comment sarcastically about the power of friendship or monarchy.

“The friends with whom you defeated Horde Prime.” That was Hen’ru. And he sounded rather doubtful, in Adora’s impression.

“Yes.” She nodded firmly. “We fought him in person. We destroyed his flagship and erased his consciousness.”

“A decapitation strike?” Hen’ru cocked his head.

“Yes.” Adora bared her teeth. She didn’t like remembering this. “It was personal.”

“Ah.”

“That’s the thing with those despots - once you take them out, the whole system starts to crumble. When we blew up Ra, his minions started infighting at once,” Jack added with a smile that reminded Adora of Catra’s… not so nice smiles.

Not that Stargate Command had known that Ra’s underlings would start a power struggle when they killed him. Adora had heard the story from Daniel, after all - they hadn’t even been aware of how large Ra’s Empire had been. Still was. But that kind

of subterfuge was allowed in diplomacy. It wasn't as if Adora and her friends were sharing all the details of just how badly they had been outmatched by Horde Prime's military, with just one antique spaceship to their name…

She still felt bad about it. Kind of.

"And you've been fighting Ra for millennia - mostly through sabotage, I take it?" Glimmer nodded at Garshaw.

"Yes." Garshaw smiled. "Our small number makes that the most effective strategy. Especially given the internal divisions in the Goa'uld Empire. Timed and executed correctly, a single act of sabotage can spark a war that causes far more losses to the Empire."

Catra nodded appreciatively, Adora saw.

As did Jack. "Yeah. A few pounds of C-4 are surprisingly effective when you place them in the right spot. Never leave home without it."

"Such was your strategy until lately, yes? The Tau'ri's, I mean." Per'sus tilted his head at Jack.

"Yeah, you know - if you don't have a fleet of spaceships with big honking guns, you make do with what you have." Jack shrugged again.

"But the situation has changed now," Glimmer cut in. "We do have naval assets in sufficient numbers to fight the Goa'uld on even grounds. We can switch from sabotage and commando operations to large-scale battles and planetary invasions. We can defeat the Goa'uld Empire for good. Just as we defeated Horde Prime."

"Horde Prime was said to rival Ra's power," Malinor, one of the female Tok'ra present, said. "Defeating him must have cost you a lot of casualties."

Adora pressed her lips together as she thought of all the people who had been killed in the war against the Horde. On both sides. Even knowing that it could have been so much worse - that Etheria could have been destroyed entirely, with everyone dead, if she hadn't defeated Horde Prime and shut down the Heart of Etheria - didn't help much.

"And it wasn't that long ago, was it?" Per'sus interjected. "You must have remarkable production and recruiting capabilities if you already feel confident to take on the Goa'uld Empire."

Adora glanced a Glimmer, but her friend nodded firmly. "We recruited Horde Prime's surviving fleet."

That surprised them - Adora could tell. As could Catra, of course; she snorted.

"They're big on recruiting and reforming people," Jack said.

"It's the best way to achieve a lasting peace." Glimmer smiled. "And it keeps your enemy from fighting to the end, shortening the war."

"Especially their soldiers," Catra added with another snort.

Adora squeezed her lover's thigh under the tale, both to reassure her - Catra had changed, and Adora loved her, no matter her past - and to remind her to keep from getting too snarky.

"Yes! Hordak, one of Horde Prime's commanders, is now our friend. And WrongHordak, another friend we made, leads the Second Fleet." Entrapta beamed at them.

Garshaw, though, didn't look very impressed. "While certainly not impossible, it's very, very rare for a Goa'uld to overcome their genetic memory and conditioning." She glanced at Teal'c for the first time since the meeting had started, Adora noted. "Or for a Jaffa. So, the feasibility of using the same strategy on the Goa'uld Empire seems questionable."

“It won’t be easy,” Glimmer said. “We’re aware of that. But people can and do change. We will make the offers to let them switch sides anyway.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. It was the right thing to do.

“If you start winning the war, many System Lords will offer to switch sides in exchange for keeping their power,” Per’sus said. “But you can’t trust them.”

“We won’t let them keep slaves or oppress anyone,” Glimmer said. “That’s non-negotiable.”

“Their slaves have been conditioned from birth to worship them as gods. Overcoming that has proven to be very difficult,” he retorted.

“We’re aware of that,” Glimmer replied. “And we’ll be working on fixing that as well.” She bared her teeth. “We have some experience with that.”

Catra snorted again, and Adora squeezed her thigh once more. She felt her lover’s tail brush over her hand before she withdrew it.

“System Lords switching sides might not keep much more than their lives,” Jack said, “but that’s still a bargain for them.”

“And yet you kept Horde Prime’s commanders in charge.” Malinor cocked her head.

“Not all of them,” Glimmer retorted. “Just those we can trust. Each of them has to be judged individually.”

“And what about their crimes?” Per’sus stared at them. “Each System Lord is responsible for countless deaths and unimaginable atrocities. Would you suggest just letting them go without punishment?”

Adora didn’t need to touch Catra to know her lover was tensing up. And she had to struggle not to frown. This was a contentious issue; she knew that very well. But she wouldn’t budge on that, either.

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Samantha Carter didn’t show any reaction to the Tok’ra’s comment, though she couldn’t help agreeing with them. Per’sus had always valued morals highly, sometimes even at the expense of efficacy, and given the Goa’uld’s cruelty and the scale of their crimes…

She blinked. She had never met Per’sus before today. This was another of Jolinar’s memories. Pressing her lips together, she focused on the mission. They were here to form an alliance - more precisely, to lay the foundation of an alliance, which diplomats would then form. Not to reconnect with the friends of a dead Tok’ra.

“People can change - even if they were raised to serve someone evil. Even the Goa’uld can change,” Adora said, meeting Per’sus’s eyes. “Refusing to grant them the chance to change wouldn’t be right.”

Sam knew Adora was sincere here. The princess honestly believed it. But she was also very, very biased because of her personal history. Because of Catra.

“And what about their victims? Should they be denied justice after all their suffering?” Per’sus asked with a hint of a sneer.

He was taking this personally as well, Sam knew. No, Jolinar had known. She clenched her jaw. Perhaps coming here had been a mistake - seeing familiar faces triggered more remnants of memories. And feeling friendly towards a stranger was more than a little disturbing. But she was an officer of the United States Air Force. She could overcome this - she knew her duty.

“What do you consider justice?” Daniel asked, leaning forward. “People have many different views of that.”

“Justice means criminals receiving what they deserve - their fair punishment,” Per’sus replied.

“And what would you consider a fair punishment?” Glimmer asked.

“For what the System Lords did, only death is sufficient.”

Sam knew the Colonel agreed with that, even though he didn’t show it.

“That sounds more like vengeance than justice,” Glimmer said. “A dead person cannot make amends. Cannot help set things right. Killing someone doesn’t bring any of their victims back.”

“But their loved ones can find closure,” Malinor pointed out. “Instead of knowing that the murderer of their family remains alive, free to commit more crimes.”

Once more, Sam had to force herself not to nod.

“If people change for good, they won’t do any more crimes,” Adora said.

“But what about atoning for their crimes?” Garshaw asked. “Do you expect people to forget what was done to them?”

“If fighting to take down the Goa’uld Empire isn’t enough to atone for your crimes, then that really sounds like vengeance and not justice,” Bow spoke up. “Just saying.”

Sam caught Garsahw nodding at that, which - weirdly - didn’t surprise her.

“And it would make it hard to get anyone to surrender or switch sides,” Glimmer added. “Which would prolong the war and cause more people to suffer.”

“Well,” the Colonel spoke up, “does anyone here think that the big bad System Lords will actually change for good? Abandon their slaves, including their hosts, and switch sides?” He shook his head. “I don’t think so, so this is a rather academic discussion - no offence to our academics, of course,” he added with a grin at Daniel and Sam.

“You plan to force them to release their hosts?” Garshaw asked. “Even if they switch sides?”

“Of course!” Adora said at once. “They don’t get to keep any slaves or oppress anyone - we already said that, didn’t we?”

Judging by the glances the High Council exchanged, Sam knew they didn’t think many Goa’uld would take up such an offer. She doubted it as well.

“Making them release their hosts and rely on volunteers to bond with them seems a sufficient show of good faith,” Malinor said.

“Good luck finding any volunteers,” the Colonel muttered.

“You show a quite remarkable mix of idealism and pragmatism,” Garshaw commented. It sounded like a compliment, but Sam wasn’t sure if it was honestly meant that way.

“We’re just doing what’s right,” Adora insisted.

“Well, everyone’s trying that, but not all agree on what’s right.” The Colonel shrugged once more. “But we’re here to talk about an alliance.”

“And our different stances towards the Goa’uld are a central part of any such talk,” Per’sus told him.

“Yes,” Glimmer spoke up. “But I think we have explored that topic sufficiently for now. Let us talk about what you expect from an alliance and what you can offer to the alliance.”

Garshaw inclined her head, then straightened. “We need more hosts. Our numbers are small because finding a willing host who consents to become our partner is a difficult task.”

Ah. This time, Sam couldn’t help wincing. That was a much more delicate issue than how to treat potential Goa’uld turncoats and prisoners.

“If you’re looking for volunteers, I don’t see any problem with that,” Adora said. “People are free to make their own decisions - provided those are informed decisions,” she added.

“Well,” the Colonel spoke up with a frown, “that’s all fine in principle, but some people have classified knowledge. Top secret knowledge which cannot be allowed to be revealed to anyone without the necessary clearance.”

Sam nodded. The way a Goa’ld and their host *blended* together would mean that anything the host knew, the Tok’ra would know as well. And that could cause all sorts of problems. Not that most of the people with such knowledge were likely to volunteer to become a host for the Tok’ra. But there were always exceptions. And even so - having a host from Earth or Etheria would give the Tok’ra immense insight into either society.

And why was the Colonel glancing at her? And why was he avoiding her eyes when she looked at him? Had she missed a cue? Or… was this a warning? He certainly couldn’t expect her to want to become a host, could he? It was ridiculous! Jolinar possessing her had been more terrifying than anything else she had experienced and survived so far!

No, the Colonel couldn’t suspect her of wanting to join the Tok’ra. He must expect her input, then. She set her jaw, but Garshaw was already replying.

“We are familiar with the need to keep crucial information safe, even if that might necessitate limiting someone’s freedom,” the Tok’ra leader said.

They had mentioned the problem of educating potential hosts, only to have to detain them, should they reject the offer, so they wouldn't spill Tok'ra secrets to the Goa'uld - voluntarily or involuntarily. "Yes." Sam nodded firmly. "The safety and security of everyone have to be considered when making and accepting such offers."

But of course, the Etherians didn't agree - or not fully. "But if someone desires to enter such a relationship with a Tok'ra, it feels wrong to deny them their wish just because they know some of your secrets," Glimmer said. "In a way, it feels not very different to prohibiting relationships across borders because you question the loyalty of someone interested in a foreigner."

Ah, yes - that would raise their hackles. Maybe literally in Catra's case, Sam thought. Even though Earth's history had proven that honey traps worked exactly like that. She almost snorted at the thought of the Tok'ra being honey traps to gather intel.

Then she realised it wasn't far off the mark - they offered a much longer life, centuries it seemed, and great physical enhancements as well as a civilisation with advanced technology in exchange for sharing your body with a loyal partner who would never leave you. That would be tempting for a great number any people with few prospects on Earth and likely on Etheria as well, even accounting for the fact that every Tok'ra was fighting in the war against the Goa'uld. So… "I think candidates should be vetted by everyone concerned, at least as long as the Goa'uld are a concern," she said, "because anyone joining the Tok'ra will likely risk being captured by the Goa'uld." Jolinar's memories of undercover missions were very fragmented, but Sam had seen enough to deduce how dangerous they were.

"Of course - it would hardly be fair if we dismissed such concerns by allies," Molinar said. "And we are aware of the damage a captured operative can cause, trust us on that. Very familiar."

Sam noticed Teal'c shifting a little, which was a surprising reaction from her stoic friend - was he remembering some action he had

taken as Apophis's First Prime? Something to, maybe, bring up in a moment of privacy. Back on Earth. If at all.

And the Etherians seemed to accept that, if a bit grudgingly - Adora was frowning.

"So, you want hosts and accept that there are security concerns," the Colonel summed up.

"Yes. And what is your primary goal for this alliance you propose?" Garshaw asked.

"Information," Glimmer replied at once. "We have the fleet to take on the Goa'uld Empire, and we're training up the ground troops, but we need as much information as we can get on the strengths and weaknesses of the System Lords so we can pick the best targets and strategy."

She was correct, of course, but relying on the Tok'ra for crucial intel would also give them an unparalleled way to influence and shape the entire campaign. Garshaw would love that - she had made her mark when she had defected after sabotaging her System Lord's military. It had earned her the trust of the Tok'ra even though she hadn't been a descendant of Egeria, and…

Sam blinked once more - another memory of Jolinar that she hadn't been aware of until now. Just how much of the Tok'ra was left in her mind, she couldn't help wondering - or fearing. Would she keep remembering such fragments? Would she *change*? *Had* she changed without noticing?

"Information we can provide," Per'sus said, as Sam had expected. "Of course, even our own information-gathering capability could be improved with more information from other sources."

"Sharing information seems an obvious course of action," Adora commented. "The more we know about our enemy, the better we can fight them."

Everyone nodded in agreement, though Sam was sure almost everyone planned to hold back some information, for various reasons. Catra's snort showed that she had the same thought.

"So, an exchange of information can be set up," Glimmer said. "What else do you expect from an alliance?"

"Magic," Garshaw told her. "Information and support to explore magitech. If magic is returning to the galaxy, we need to be prepared for it - and after a thousand years, none of us has any experience with it. Meanwhile, the System Lords can rely on their memories from the time when magic was ubiquitous."

"If Goa'uld cannot use magic, I wouldn't expect them to make extensive use of it - it might have made them look weak," Daniel commented.

"They did suppress such knowledge amongst their slave populations, but at the very least, they would have taken measures to protect themselves against attacks using magic. And, as you told Anise, anyone can work with magitech, provided they have access to the resources only a magician can create," Garshaw said.

Per'sus looked a little sceptical, Sam thought. Sak'ram, Hen'ru and Salesh had remained more or less quiet - as throughout the meeting so far - but at least Hen'ru looked interested, as did Molinar.

"We can do that," Entrapta said. "And we're very interested in your own technology!" she added with a beaming smile. "It's so fascinating!"

Both Glimmer and the Colonel seemed a little annoyed at her butting in, but Sam had expected that. And it didn't really matter - Anise and Jakar would have told the Tok'ra High Council about Entrapta already.

Though there was another delicate topic to cover: Technology. While Sam wouldn't have expected this situation a year ago, as

part of the Alliance, they had, through the Etherians, access to technology that was more advanced than the Goa'uld's - or the Tok'ra's - at least in some areas.

Which meant that negotiating technology transfers would be amongst the most difficult parts of any alliance treaty to negotiate. Or should be, unless the Etherians planned to simply share their technology like they had with Earth, provided some basic conditions were met.

Which, Sam realised as Glimmer nodded, they probably were.

Sharing intel and technology, providing hosts - the Colonel wouldn't be the only one with deep reservations about such an alliance.

Well, the devil was, as always, in the details.

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"...and support in the field, as you call it, would strain our means too much. We are not ready to wage open war against the Goa'uld - we fight from the shadows with subterfuge, sabotage and assassinations. We aren't *Jaffa*," Sak'ram said - with a nasty glance at Teal'c, Catra noticed.

"We don't expect squads of Tok'ra commandos, but advisors and intelligence agents attached to an invasion force would be a great help. If something unexpected appears, shorter lines of communication would save lives - on all sides." Sam smiled at the Tok'ra. She seemed rather invested in this, in Catra's opinion. This tunnel-growing technology better was worth it.

"You seem to care almost more for saving the soldiers of the enemy than for saving their slaves." And Per'sus had to pipe up again. He'd made it clear long ago that he certainly only cared about the victims of the System Lords, not their soldiers or the Goa'uld themselves.

Catra could understand that, to some degree. But then, if Adora had been like him… She clenched her teeth together. This had become a drag. They had some preliminary agreements on the core issues, but now they were talking details and circling around each other. That sort of stuff was what diplomats and princesses were for!

"Actually, with the bot network we're building, we shouldn't have any issues with long-range communications. We won't need an open Stargate, just a dedicated faster-than-light communication array to contact planets, and while those aren't portable - though we could construct bots with those instead of weapons - they could easily relay calls from communicators to the network. So, communication lag shouldn't be an issue." Entrapta beamed, and Catra suppressed a sigh - her friend was missing the point.

"Even if we could call the Tok'ra whenever we want from across the galaxy," she said instead, "they wouldn't be aware of our situation. We'd have to brief them before they could advise us."

"Yes," Glimmer agreed. "That's why advisors in the field would be useful."

She was right, of course. But Tok'ra advisors would also be useful for spying on the Alliance. And influencing the Alliance military decisions. So, why didn't the Tok'ra want that? Did they really have so few agents that they couldn't spare enough?

"Well, as soon as we get more hosts, we will have more people available for such missions," Salesh said.

Now, that could be true - or just a cheap way to force their hand. It was hard to tell. But Catra didn't think that the Tok'ra had been very open with them so far. Jakar claimed he had been, but he was a trained and experienced spy and would have carefully chosen what information he shared or 'let slip'. And none of the Tok'ra had reacted to Entrapta mentioning the bot network, even though Catra was sure they had not missed that bit.

"Well…" O'Neill rubbed his neck and rolled his shoulder. "I don't know about you, but I could use a break. I'm not getting any younger, after all."

Catra nodded, stretching her arms over her head. "We've been at this for a while."

"Indeed," Garshaw said. "Let's take a break. It's almost dinner time. Let us schedule the next meeting for after dinner?"

"And refrain from continuing our current discussion at the table," Per'sus added with a faint smile.

"Good luck making Anise not talk about magitech," Malinor told him with a grin.

"Or you?" Per'sus shot back.

Catra snorted at the exchange.

"Oh, we can talk about magitech - there are many aspects of it that were not mentioned yet in this discussion," Entrapta said, nodding enthusiastically. "And there's all the technology that we haven't touched yet, of course."

"Oh?" Malinor cocked her head. "I am looking forward to our discussion then."

"So am I!"

Catra kept a polite smile on her face while they left the room, but as soon as they were inside their quarters and Sam and Entrapta had done their anti-surveillance thing, she sighed. "Now, that was a drag."

"We've been making great progress for a first meeting with an unknown kingdom," Glimmer reported.

"Still a drag," Catra insisted. "We went around in circles for so long, I started to get dizzy."

“It looked more as if you were getting sleepy.” Glimmer’s smile had too many teeth.

“Naw. I would have taken a nap in Adora’s lap if I had been sleepy.” Catra grinned at her.

“Catra!” Adora blushed. “You can’t do that in a meeting!”

“You mean ‘shouldn’t’,” Catra corrected her.

“You’re not doing this!”

“Of course not - I’m bored, not sleepy.” Catra shrugged.

“Anyway,” Glimmer said. “Let’s go over the meeting so far to refine our approach.”

Ugh. “The Tokra want hosts and won’t help us until they get hosts,” Catra said. “They could be telling the truth, or they could be lying about their numbers. And they really want magitech.”

Glimmer frowned at her. “It’s a serious issue.”

Cara shrugged in return. “That’s my take on it. We’re dealing with spies, saboteurs and assassins.”

“That’s an oversimplification,” Daniel spoke up, “but the cultural influence of a millennia-long conflict centred on hiding, infiltration and covert operations shouldn’t be underestimated. We’re dealing with a unique culture for which we don’t have existing references. It’s really fascinating how they have built their society.”

Ugh. Another lecture. Catra hopped on Adora’s lap, prompting a yelp.

If she had to listen to this rehash, she might as well get the most comfortable she could.

Unfortunately, after Daniel finished his five minutes of speculation about the Tok’ra culture, Adora thought it was her turn to

speculate about the relationships between the members of the High Council. So Catra found herself removed from her favourite napping and lounging spot in favour of watching her lover improvise a whiteboard with the help of Emily's side. Sometimes, Adora's tendency to overprepare for a meeting was cute, but Catra had spent hours in a meeting already, and dinner, which likely would be another sort of meeting despite the Tok'ra's words, was still fifteen minutes away. Which was fifteen minutes too long to sit and listen to amateur analysis of facial expressions and body language.

In hindsight, watching the Earth media trying to analyse the relationships between everyone in Catra's circle of friends based on their body language had been a mistake. Sure, it had been kind of funny at the time, but apparently, Adora had taken it seriously.

And Catra was quite fed up with sitting still and listening to people talk without any results, and not even Adora there to cuddle. So she got up, stretched, and announced: "I'm going to prowl a little before dinner. Been sitting down for too long."

"'Prowl'?" Daniel asked.

Catra shrugged. "Wander around, see the sights, poke my nose into stuff that looks interesting." Adora pouted, but Catra just had to do *something* instead of nothing. "Toodles!"

"'Toodles'?" Glimmer asked.

"Ask Daniel!" Catra told her as she stepped out of the room.

"Don't start a diplomatic incident!" she heard before the door closed behind her.

She snorted. As if! They had permission to explore the entire base. And it would be rude if they didn't after the Tok'ra had gone and created the whole base just for this meeting.

Not to mention that, decoy or not, Catra wanted to know more about the base's layout and how it compared to Horde bunkers and forward bases. If they routinely used such bases to fool the Goa'uld into thinking they had left a planet, then the base had to look close to the real thing. Reasonably close, at least. Which meant weapons lockers, command centres, barracks and choke points should net some information.

Sure this had been a rush job just for this meeting, but at least in the Horde, a rush job meant grunts were falling back on what they had been trained to do instead of getting creative.

Grinning, she picked the next few turns and crossings at random and started to explore.

After five minutes, she had found half a dozen empty quarters, an unused mess hall, bathrooms without anything in it and what must have been a fake armoury. Which meant it was getting boring. And she hadn't met anyone to bother either. She could check the transporter room or follow the scent of food to the kitchen or whatever dining room the Tok'ra were preparing…

Her ears twitched when she picked up some murmuring from another empty bathroom down the hallway. Was that a Tok'ra who had sneaked away for some private talk? Or just to bitch about their superior officers? Catra had done both in the Horde as a cadet with Adora.

She grinned. This could be interesting. And she could find out how good the Tok'ra were at noticing her when she was making an effort at sneaking. Valuable data, as Entrapta would say.

Soon, she could make out what was being said - those doors didn't block sound well enough to fool her ears.

"...and they claim to have a fleet rivalling the Empire's and are preparing to wage war against the Goa'uld, requesting information and support from the Tok'ra. They're currently in a temporary base on the planet but may move back to their home planet or

the planet of the Tau'ri soon to fetch diplomats for another meeting with the Tok'ra."

Catra frowned. That sounded… well, like the Tok'ra version of what Adora and the others had been doing. Only… She wasn't an expert on the Tok'ra or a scholar like Daniel. In fact, Catra would be the first to admit that she wasn't particularly experienced at picking up alien culture stuff.

But the man - it was a male voice, at least - was talking to someone who wasn't present since she hadn't heard anyone else.

And he sounded as if he didn't consider himself a Tok'ra.

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The Tok’ra Part 4

P34-353J, December 4th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“I think I found a spy amongst the Tok’ra.”

Jack O’Neill narrowed his eyes as he snapped his head to stare at Catra. “What?” he asked before he could control himself.

“I think I found a spy amongst the Tok’ra,” she repeated herself, nodding slowly.

“So, it wasn’t my hearing going bad,” Jack quipped even as he grimaced.

“A spy?” Adora asked.

“Yes. I overheard someone talking about us and about the Tok’ra as if both of us were strangers. And he was talking to a communicator or recording device - there was nobody else in the bathroom,” Catra replied. She tapped her nose with one finger. “Didn’t smell anyone else either.”

“Ew!” Glimmer frowned.

“Not that!” Catra rolled her eyes. “Anyway, I got his scent but I didn’t catch more than a glimpse of him from behind - those tunnels don’t offer many hiding spots.” She pouted. “The Horde hallways were better for that. If we get the Tok’ra tunnel technology, we need to keep that in mind.”

“Wouldn’t that help a spy as well?” Daniel asked. A moment later, he blinked as he got the joke. “Oh.”

Jack snorted at his friend’s expression. “Yeah. So, you’re not sure if it was a spy.”

Catra shrugged. “I’m no expert. It could just be a cultural quirk of the Tok’ra to talk like that. But… you don’t go to an empty, out-of-

the-way bathroom in a decoy base to talk like that if it's perfectly normal."

Jack nodded - his gut agreed.

"Well, we don't know much about Tok'ra culture," Daniel said. "Though it's very likely that they are heavily influenced by their conflict with the Goa'uld, which is fought undercover with spies and saboteurs." He slowly nodded. "Isolating yourself like that could be a cultural quirk."

"I didn't find anyone else doing that," Catra objected.

"There can't be too many Tok'ra in a decoy base," Daniel defended his theory. Or hypothesis, or whatever the science guys called it.

"I noticed two dozen," Catra retorted. "Six guards in the transport room, six guards in the ready room, five people preparing the mess hall and the meal, and the rest attending the Councilors. Plus Anise and Jakar."

"They haven't left for the actual base?" Carter asked with a frown.

"Did you spy on them?" Adora sounded shocked.

Catra smirked. "I didn't. I just took a walk through the base and listened - and smelt. It's not spying if I do what they told us we can do."

Jack snorted again, but he couldn't really enjoy the humour. "Let's go back to the spy. We've got a potential spy amongst our potential allies. And they already know too much." Just knowing that Etheria existed and was about to fight them was enough to lose the Alliance the element of surprise.

"Well, we don't know if he managed to pass it on," Catra said. "He'd need an FTL communication device to inform anyone outside the system. Of course, if he was talking to another spy on the planet, or a listening post - or a ship hidden in the system…" She grimaced. "That would be bad."

“Well, I guess we have to find out,” Jack said. “ASAP.” If they managed to plug the leak before the Goa’uld got the information, they might be able to salvage this clusterfuck. But could they trust an ally who let a spy into their most important meeting? And what else had the spy already gathered?

“But how?” Daniel asked. “And we don’t know if this is a spy,” he added.

Not by asking nicely, that was sure. Jack sighed. He really hated what they had to do. “We’ll have to talk to our first spy.”

Daniel blinked again. “Our first spy?”

“Jakar,” Glimmer told him with a grin.

“I thought that you didn’t trust him.” Daniel still looked confused.

Jack didn’t trust or like any spook, snake or not. “He’s our best bet to solve this mess,” he explained. The odds that Jakar was also a mole were far too low - and contacting him wouldn’t look as suspicious to the spy as contacting a councillor would.

“And then we lay a trap for the spy?” Catra grinned again, looking eager.

Jack shrugged. “Perhaps. It depends on the Tok’ra protocols for this.” They were sure to have protocols for handing moles - you didn’t survive a shadow war for so long without having procedures in place for that. Hell, Jack wouldn’t even be too surprised if the snakes already suspected the mole, and this was part of a plan to make him reveal himself. Although he wouldn’t be surprised if the standard procedure was to use enhanced interrogation on any suspect - they were dealing with snakes, after all. “Now, let’s see if we can contact Jakar without alerting anyone. Too bad we can’t just call him.”

Entrapta beamed. “We could call him - I just need to get us connected to their communication network!”

Jack blinked. That sounded like…

“You want to hack their comms?” Even Carter sounded surprised.

“Yes?” Entrapta blinked. “Well, we could ask for access, but we’re trying to be subtle, right?”

Sometimes, Entrapta was a pain in the butt. But sometimes, like now, Jack loved her.

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Adora stared at Entrapta and Sam. “Dinner will be starting in a minute or two,” she reminded them. “We’ll probably meet Jakar there and can tell him there.”

“Aw.” Entrapta pouted. “But what if the spy is also there? We can’t talk to Jakar without drawing attention, right?”

Adora sighed. “I think we can pass him a message without being spotted.”

“A slip of paper or something. Or just ask him if he wants to discuss our secrets afterwards,” Catra added with a grin. But she quickly grew serious. “I also need to identify the spy first. If he’s not at the dinner, I’ll make an excuse to get out and see if I can find him.”

“If he’s not at dinner, we can just tell the High Council,” Daniel said.

“We can’t risk that the spy is watching,” Jack objected. “And a paper message might not cut it - I think the Tok’ra expect us to continue our meeting after dinner,” Jack cut in. “Which means we won’t be able to meet discreetly with him and plan things.”

“And we don’t have time to hack the comms,” Bow said. “And hacking them would also be quite rude since we’re guests.” He frowned at Entrapta.

“But we’re helping them,” Entrapta retorted. “And I think I can work on this during dinner. I can use my goggles and my hair to work while I eat - I’ve done it before, no problem!”

“That would be rude as well,” Glimmer commented.

“It would be rude? But I would do it under the table!” Entrapta looked surprised. “No one ever minds if Adora and Catra do their thing under the table while we eat or talk.”

Adora felt her face heat up. “We’re just holding hands sometimes!” she blurted out when the others stared at her. And she was sure they knew that!

“And thighs, and tails, and…” Catra nodded. Adora glared at her, but her lover shrugged. “Glimmer and Bow do the same. Minus the tail, of course.”

Adora switched her frown to her blushing friends. Hypocrites!

Then Jack cleared his throat. “Can we skip the handholding debate and focus on how we contact our spy without alerting the other spy?” He looked at Entrapta. “Can you contact him without getting caught?”

“Well, is it rude or not? We’re not supposed to be rude, are we?” Entrapta scrunched her nose and then nodded. “But yes, I think I can hack the communications. Their protocols are good, but not as good as Horde Prime’s - and if I can work through dinner, that’s ample time! I’m not getting shot at either, this time!”

Glimmer sighed, closing her eyes for a moment. “But hacking someone’s systems is not just rude, it’s generally a hostile act - even if you do it for their own good.”

“Does that mean I shouldn’t be doing it? Or does that mean I shouldn’t get caught?” Entrapta asked.

Adora knew who was to blame for that question. She would have to talk to Catra once they were home. But first, they had to sort

this out. She took a step forward. “We should inform Jakar and then let the Tok’ra handle this. The spy isn’t a member of the High Council, which means he can inform them without risking that the spy will notice.” The Tok’ra had been fighting the Goa’uld in a spy war for a long, long time. They should know how to handle spies. If they couldn’t trust the Tok’ra to manage this, they couldn’t trust them with anything sensitive, anyway.

“The Tok’ra have survived against the Goa’uld for millennia,” Teal’c pointed out. “This will not be the first such spy they have encountered.”

Jack didn’t like that; Adora could tell from his expression. But Daniel and Sam were nodding in agreement, as were Glimmer and Bow. And Catra…

…was shrugging. “Might even be a plan to see how we react,” she said.

“I could find that out if I hack their systems!” Entrapta smiled.

“I don’t think we need to do that,” Glimmer told her.

“At least not right now,” Catra added. “We might want to test their computer security later.”

“OK!” Entrapta beamed. “So, I can enjoy talking to Anise without being rude!”

Adora was about to tell her lover a few things about how to treat your allies, but then someone knocked at the door - it was time for dinner. They had run out of time.

“I’ll be a bit late - I’ll write a message and then slip it into Jakar’s pocket,” Catra told her with a grin. “Go ahead!”

Adora didn’t want to go ahead, but she saw no better solution. “Alright.”

But when the door opened, Jakar was standing there. “Are you ready for dinner?” he asked.

Adora wanted to palm her face. They should have expected this!

“Ah, yes… we are, but there’s a tiny little issue we need to solve first,” Jack said with a toothy grin.

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Samantha Carter smiled a little ruefully at the Colonel’s antics. If this wasn’t Jakar, but Martouf, the levity wouldn’t go over well, but the Tok’ra spy had proven to have a sense of humour - probably with a similar dose of gallows humour as the Colonel’s.

And indeed, he was smiling as he raised his eyebrows. “Somehow, I suspect that this won’t be a little thing, Colonel.”

And then he lost his smile when Catra peeked her head through the door and checked the corridor outside, her ears twitching as she sniffed the air and announced. “Clear.”

“It seems you expect treachery,” Jakar said as the door closed behind him. “And since you chose to tell me, you do not believe it’s on the part of the Tok’ra. At least not as a whole.”

The Colonel’s smile grew a little wider. “It’s so nice to work with someone who’s quick on the uptake. Yes, we discovered what might be a spy.”

And there was only one group who’d send a spy into the Tok’ra’s ranks.

“What did you discover?” Jakar asked with narrowed eyes.

“I overheard someone that sounded like making a report in a deserted bathroom here,” Catra told him. “He didn’t sound as if he considered himself a Tok’ra. I didn’t get a look at his face, but I can identify him if I’m close enough.”

“Ah.” Jakar slowly nodded. “Then we need you to identify him to investigate further. Fortunately, we know all the individuals present in this base - and travel is restricted. So the suspect must still be inside the base. Do you need him to speak to identify him?”

Catra cocked her head. “I just need to be close. It’s not one of the High Council.”

She didn’t say that she could identify the spy by scent, but Jakar would expect that. Or, Sam amended her thoughts, he might suspect some magical or psychic ability like Melog’s. That would have thrown some of the Tok’ra she knew for a loop. That they hadn’t mentioned Melog yet in the discussions meant that they probably wanted to secure an alliance first before touching on that subject. Or… She shook her head. They had to focus on dealing with the spy, not on hypothetical developments for future negotiations.

“Good. That leaves their aides, the guards and the kitchen staff, but I can work with that.” Jakar nodded sharply. “Please come with me now - we can’t afford to cause the spy to suspect something because we take too long.”

Sam nodded but noticed that the Colonel seemed a bit reluctant. Despite his words, he didn’t really trust the Tok’ra to handle this, she realised. Well, that couldn’t be helped - they couldn’t exactly launch an investigation into the matter by themselves as guests of the Tok’ra. And the Tok’ra knew how to handle spies; this wasn’t the first time they had to deal with a mole, even though she couldn’t recall any details.

Sam frowned as she realised she wasn’t sure if she should be glad or annoyed that she only had fragments of Jolinar’s memories about this topic. How could she make sound decisions if she couldn’t trust her information? But they were walking towards the dining room. It was time to focus on that, not on the past - or the spy. Even if it was hard.

“Did you construct the dining room for this occasion, or is that like an officer’s mess? Do you have officers?” Entrapta asked. “I know that spies generally don’t operate like line soldiers, and you’re pretty much all spies, right?”

“We have our leaders and commanders,” Jakar said. “Though we have a much flatter hierarchy than you have, based on what I noticed as your guest. Much fewer ranks, for one.” He grinned. “Shaped by our needs - and, unfortunately, our small numbers.”

“Which will grow as soon as you get access to more hosts, or so you’ve told us,” the Colonel said. “Do you have a bunch of little Tok’ra on ice who are just waiting for hosts?”

Jakar laughed once more. “Something like that, Colonel.”

And wasn’t that a clear hint at them having a queen? Or was it misdirection? Sam really wished she had access to Jolinar’s memories to verify this. Although… would any field operative of the Tok’ra actually know such crucial information? The Goa’uld would want nothing more than cripple their enemies’ ability to replenish their forces. Kill their queen, and the Tok’ra would die out sooner or later.

“And here we are,” Jakar announced before opening a door, revealing a room with a large set of crescent-shaped tables, not unlike the ones in the meeting room. The High Council, and Anise, were present - but so were half a dozen other Tok’ra whom Sam hadn’t seen before. No, whom she hadn’t seen at the meeting - Martouf was there. And another who looked familiar but whose name she couldn’t remember. And…

Her trail of thought was broken when she noticed Catra grabbing Jakar’s arm and pointing at the food on a round table in the centre between the two others. “Is that fish? The dish in front of the guy there?” She pointed at one of the unknown Tok’ra.

Ah. Not the most subtle, in Sam’s - or Jolinar’s - opinion. But Jakar would understand.

So, they had identified their suspect. But having them at the dinner complicated matters somewhat, in Sam's opinion. She didn't know if everyone present could keep up appearances without letting slip tier suspicion.

"Sam! Entrapta! Bow!" Anise made a beeline towards them. "Let's sit down! I have a lot of questions we should discuss!"

Well, Sam thought as Entrapta all but dragged her and Bow towards the Tok'ra scientist, at least for Entrapta, it'll be easy. She doubted her friend would spare a thought on the spy - if she had even noticed Catra marking him.

*****

The dish was fish! Fried fish! Talk about hitting two enemies with one shot! Catra smiled widely as she finished the morsel she had been given to get a taste - it was really good! - before shovelling more on her plate. "You know, this is much better than the Earth-style dinners," she said. "Or the Bright Moon-style dinners."

"What?" Adora cocked her head at her as she filled her own plate.

"What do you mean?" Ah, Glimmer had overheard her - as planned.

"It's one big *buffet*," Catra explained. "You don't have to wait for a servant to bring you food, you don't have to eat what is put in front of you, you can pick what you like and then load up on it. And you don't insult anyone if you don't eat some inedible mess that some weirdo thinks is tasty."

"It wasn't inedible! Your taste buds are just wired weirdly after having only had Horde rations for years!" Glimmer protested. "And it was one time! We have competent staff who take notes on what people like to eat and what they don't like."

Catra smirked. "Well, but I still don't get fish every meal." She nudged Adora, who hadn't reacted to the little exchange. "Say, what do you think of switching all meals to buffet-style affairs?"

“Oh. Uhm.” Adora tried unsuccessfully to hide how she had loaded her plate mostly with some of the marinated meat bits, Catra noticed. “I would think it would affect logistics - since you usually would have more food wasted when people left one kind of dish alone and picked others. And, uh, if you only made enough overall so someone had to eat the worse food, there might be trouble in the chow line once all the good food is gone.” And now she was looking at the dish she had left out - some greenish stuff that looked like a partially-bleached cactus and smelt terrible.

Catra sighed and shook her head. “We’re guests. Don’t eat stuff you don’t like,” she whispered.

“But…”

“No buts.” Catra bumped her with her hip to steer her back to their table. “Besides, our hosts are waiting for you so they can start talking your ear off.” Apparently, it was considered rude amongst Tok’ra to talk at the buffet or something. Daniel probably figured it out, not that Catra cared to ask.

“Oh, OK!”

And that was how you handled Adora.

Catra glanced at the spy when they returned to the table. He was eating the cactus stuff, she noticed. And his name was Cordesh - Firnan for the host - according to the introductions. Damn, trying to keep two sets of names for every Tok’ra was going to be a hassle.

“Ah, you like mat’o,” Per’sus commented from across the table as they took their seats. They had taken their meals first - as Jakar had explained, to show it wasn’t poisoned and so the guests’ meals wouldn’t grow cold before they ate. Since they hadn’t eaten yet, it didn’t make too much sense, but then, neither did Bright Moon’s table manners.

“The fish?” Catra cocked her head. “Yes, it’s very tasty.”

“Fish?” The Tok’ra blinked. “Ah. Mat’o is not fish - it’s fried mat’a brain.”

Catra froze for a moment, staring at her plate. It tasted like fish. Mostly.

“What are mat’a?” Glimmer asked.

“Legless reptiles,” Per’sus explained.

So, she was eating snake brains. Catra blinked, then shrugged. Who cared? It was good!

Glimmer, though, stared at her own small portion of mat’o. Hah!

“As we have gathered, let us eat in peace and harmony,” Garshaw said.

A moment later, people started eating, and Catra dug in. Everyone else did so as well - though Entrapta and Anise needed a reminder from Sam and Bow.

“So, are all your meals eaten in this style?” Daniel asked after the first bite. “Or is this reserved for such occasions?”

“It is a sign of pride to offer a wide variety of food to your guests,” Hen’ru told him.

“And when you aren’t hosting guests?” Daniel followed up at once.

“Then you usually just make whatever dish you and your partner - or partners - like,” Hen’ru replied with a grin.

Well, that sounded sensible, in Catra’s opinion. But she wasn’t here to learn about Tok’ra dining habits. So, as Daniel continued to pelt the Tok’ra with questions about their culture and society - nicely abusing the fact that they weren’t supposed to talk about the alliance - Catra paid attention to the spy.

He seemed to be torn between trying to follow the conversation between Daniel and the High Council and trying to listen in to what Entrapta, Sam, Bow, Anise and Malinor were discussing.

Good luck, Catra thought with a smirk hidden behind her drink. Her ears picked up the conversation just fine - but it was far too technical to understand, and she didn't think the spy was a scientist either.

Cordesh must have realised that as well since he started asking Daniel questions about Earth society. "So, your planet is divided between many independent countries, each with its own culture and leaders?"

"Yes," Daniel said without hesitation. "Though we have shared rules and values."

"Precious few of those," Catra heard O'Neill mutter under his breath, and she had to suppress a chuckle.

"And Etheria is the same?"

"Yes," Glimmer told him.

"It must be fascinating to live in such a place, but if I may hazard a guess, trying to rule the planet would be very difficult with so many different factions," Cordesh said.

Ah, that was his game - he was looking for weaknesses. As expected.

"We're not planning to rule the planet," Glimmer told him.

"And neither are we," Daniel added.

"But how are you supposed to fight a war with such… disunity?" another aide asked.

"We only take the willing into an alliance," Adora told him. "There are enough people willing to fight."

“Ah.”

“Fascinating, To have so many people that you can let them sit out a war against the Empire…”

As the discussion shifted a little, Catra noticed that one of the aides, Martouf, wasn’t taking part. He was looking at Sam instead. And his expression… Catra thought it looked familiar, somehow. And pained.

Weird.

*****

More weird food. Jack O’Neill liked to think he wasn’t a picky eater - in the field, you quickly learned how to eat anything edible, and the Air Force wasn’t a Chair Force no matter what the crayon-eaters claimed - but eating fried snake brain was something only Daniel could enjoy. And Catra, obviously, but, well, she was an alien. No, Jack stuck to snake meat, thank you very much. And some sort of not-quite-sweet potatoes as a side dish instead of bleached cactus.

Not that he was about to ask what exactly he was eating, of course. That way lay the sort of unpleasant realisation that you were living through dessert in Indiana Jones and the Temple of Doom - a lesson everyone except for Daniel learned quickly in Stargate Command.

He bit down on another forkful, chewing slowly while he listened to Per’sus talking to Daniel about the way Tok’ra supply lines worked. Well, they were talking about how they mixed imported food and locally sourced grub, but that was what it worked out to.

He glanced at the spy - Catra hadn’t been very subtle with pointing out him. The snake had stopped gathering intel from Carter and the others and was now listening to Daniel spill information about Earth’s culture, mainly food and hospitality. Mostly safe topics, then - even though a spy might be able to use

some of the information. But that would only matter if they couldn't stop the spy from passing on his intel.

Damn, he hated playing the nice guest while a spook was trying to stab them in the back! He would love to just wander over, then smash the man's face into his plate and just… Jack took a deep breath.

"I see. With the way your society moves around, the only constant food sources are those able to be grown on many different planets - and those so prized, you take considerable effort to source them," Daniel said. "So, your culture's culinary traditions are split between adapting new recipes with every new planet and old traditional dishes that you can only eat on special occasions."

Even a communist snake spy society has to have ways to reward their elite, Jack thought.

"Indeed," Per'sus said.

"It will be interesting to discover how this will change once we have defeated the Goa'uld," Glimmer commented. "Once you don't have to hide any more."

She said it as if this was inevitable. Jack would chalk her confidence up to naivety and inexperience, but the Etherians had been through a decades-long war already. Still, the Goa'uld Empire was different from the Horde.

"You speak as if our victory was set in stone," Per'sus echoed Jack's thoughts somewhat.

Glimmer tilted her head. "We are confident that we'll defeat the Empire, yes. And planning ahead is a good idea. But more importantly, you can't fight a war if you're all about gloom and doom. If you expect to lose, you tend to lose."

"Yes!" Adora chimed in with a nod. "The moral is to the physical as three to one, as one of Earth's greatest generals once said. If soldiers don't believe in victory, they'll believe in defeat."

An alien magical space princess quoting Napoleon… Jack chuckled. "It's not quite that simple," he said, "and we shouldn't be overconfident, but you're more or less correct - we will beat the Goa'uld." Or die trying. Of course, there would be efforts to ensure that even in defeat, Earth would survive. Though more organised than what had happened during Apophis's attack. Just shoving people through the gate, without almost no thought about how they were supposed to survive on the other side, no real preparations to start a self-sufficient colony… Everyone involved had done their best to forget that debacle.

"I want to share your confidence," Garsahw said. "But my experience keeps me from doing so. We've struggled for so long, just holding out was a victory. We've seen our hopes dashed multiple times, and harsh defeats have taught us to expect the worst."

Well, Jack knew what she was talking about. Somewhat, at least - the United States hadn't really fought such a lopsided war on the weaker side until they had started Stargate Command. But Jack had done enough stuff with spooks to expect the worst, too - even if the Etherians tended to make that hard these days.

And his team, of course. Daniel with his enthusiasm and idealism, Carter with her genius and stubborn drive, Teal'c, who had risked it all, abandoned his entire life and changed sides because he had seen something in SG-1 that Jack hadn't, at the time…

He smiled and nodded at Garshaw. "I know the feeling. But you can't just get… stuck in it." He wasn't going to say anything cheesy about losing the future by clinging to the past. His team would probably assume he had been taken over by a Goa'uld.

"We'll see," Garshaw said, obviously still sceptical. Jack wouldn't have expected anything else.

"What can we do to prove to you that we are telling the truth? That we can make good on our claims?" Adora asked, leaning forward.

Per'sus tilted his head at her. "You've made a lot of claims about magic. Such as that it allows you to heal people that even a Goa'uld healing device cannot help."

Adora's face lit up with a smile as Jack suppressed a sigh.

He should have expected that.

*****

"I can heal them, yes," Adora said confidently. She could heal anyone. Then she blinked. "Uh… do you mean a host or a symbiont? We haven't tried yet if my healing power will expel a Goa'uld from an unwilling host, so I don't know what will happen to a Tok'ra."

"The host is dying," Per'sus said.

"Oh." Adora winced. If she accidentally killed a Tok'ra symbiont while trying to heal the host… "It would be safer if the symbiont would leave the host. Just for the healing. It won't take long at all." She smiled as reassuringly as she could.

Per'sus didn't look like he felt very assured, but he nodded. "That can… be arranged."

"Great. Where are they?" She almost looked around but controlled herself.

"They're not in the base," Per'sus told her. "But we can visit them later."

Ah, they were in the real base on the planet - that made sense, of course. Adora nodded. But… could they leave the base here, when a spy was on the loose? Or was that an opportunity to catch the spy? A trap, maybe?

She nodded. "Good."

Wait, had Jakar even told the High Council about the spy yet? Adora hadn't seen any exchange between the agent and the councillors, but she wasn't a spy - she could've easily missed it. And she couldn't ask Catra right now, in the middle of their dinner with the Tok'ra.

She took another bite from the excellent grilled snake meat and sneaked a glance at her lover. Catra looked… slightly annoyed. So, something wasn't right or not going according to how she thought things should be going. Or she didn't like the food - but she'd just gone to get a third helping, so that wasn't it.

It looks like I've made a mistake, Adora thought.

"I thought you needed to… 'unlock' magic on a planet to be able to use it," Garshaw said. "Do you have a magitech healing device?"

Adora shook her head, wincing slightly at the memory of the jungle zombies. "No, we don't have such devices. The one we found, made by the Ancients, ah, didn't quite work."

Catra snorted. "It made zombies."

"Zombies?" Per'sus cocked his head to the side with a puzzled expression.

"It's a Tau'ri name for animated corpses that attack the living. Supposedly fictional, but as we found out, the Ancients managed to create them for real," Glimmer explained. "Accidentally, we think."

"Oh." Garshaw glanced at Per'sus. "That seems… surprisingly inept for the Ancients. The Goa'uld healing devices work, after all."

"We think it was a prototype or something," Adora said.

"Ah." Garshaw nodded again. "And are you working on fixing its flaws?"

"No," Adora said. Not to her knowledge, at least. Entrapta and Sam were working on other projects. And no one else had the skills to work with Ancient magitech.

"But how can you heal people on a planet without magic and magitech?" Garshaw asked once more.

"Oh, that's because I'm She-Ra," Adora replied. "My powers are tied into magic itself. I can always use it." She didn't know if that was the fault of the First Ones or something else, but that wasn't something she liked talking about.

"Her title is 'Princess of Power'," Glimmer added with a grin. "She can use magic in space as well."

"Magic doesn't work off-planet?" Per'sus nodded.

Adora nodded. "Magitech works, though."

"Magic requires life," Glimmer explained. "Or at least the potential for life. And that means planets that can bear life. Magitech circumvents this by using something else as a power source, even though the effects are magical."

"I see," Garshaw said, glancing at Entrapta and the others. "I assume they're already past discussing the fundamentals."

Catra chuckled. "Oh, yes. Entrapta, Sam and Bow are probably already planning devices to augment existing technology with Anise."

That made the councillors wince a little, even Adora could tell. And *that* made her want to wince since Catra's ears would've picked up what the others were talking about, so that probably wasn't idle speculation.

"You seem unhappy about that," Jack commented. "Don't you trust Anise?"

“She’s an excellent scientist,” Per’sus said. “Innovative and bold. Sometimes perhaps a bit too bold.”

Oh. “Like Entrapta, then,” Adora said, nodding.

And that made the others wince more.

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“...so we could use a magitech device to enhance your crystal growing technology - and with a decision matrix from a bot, we could have a smart base able to grow tunnels and tools where they want and need them!” Entrapta beamed.

If we manage to refine the Tok’ra technology to include more complex tools, Samantha Carter mentally amended her friend’s statement.

“Yes, if your other hypothesises are proven true,” Anise said. “Which is a not insignificant assumption - we have been using and refining our crystal technology for a long time.”

“But never with magitech!” Entrapta nodded several times. “It’s a game changer, as people say on Earth.”

“A ‘game changer’?” Anise cocked her head in a slightly alien manner. “Do you treat this as a game?”

“It’s a figure of speech,” Sam explained. “We don’t treat it as a game.”

“Even though science is fun!” Entrapta agreed. “As long as no one gets hurt seriously,” she added.

Anise nodded in apparent agreement. “Yes, it is. And there are few things as satisfying and rewarding as seeing your projects work out and your hypothesises proven true.”

“Yes!” Once more, Entrapta nodded enthusiastically.

Sam agreed as well, though she didn't voice it like that. There were a number of more important things, after all. Defeating the Goa'uld. Friends. Family - at least, it was supposed to be more important, even if it might not always work out like that.

She noticed her plate was empty and excused herself to get a bit more food - the dishes were excellent. Some, she hadn't had in quite some time. Jolinar hadn't had them, she corrected herself - Sam had never tasted them before today.

Still, she did like them and started filling her plate with a few more kren and liso'n bits - she particularly liked them.

"Jolinar loved them."

Sam managed not to gasp despite her surprise and turned to face who had addressed her. Oh.

It was Martouf. The Tok'ra she knew the most about, even though it was still very little. But he had been Jolinar's friend, and most of the fragmented memories Sam remembered featured him. And he had just learned of Jolinar's death a few hours ago.

So Sam smiled and nodded. "Yes. I don't remember too much of their life, but when I tasted kren and liso'n, the taste was familiar."

Martouf nodded and repeated himself. "Jolinar loved them. Unlike most of us, who prefer the traditional, rare dishes, she loved the food here." His eyes lost focus for a moment, and his expression grew a little sad.

Her? Jolinar's last host had been male, Sam knew - she doubted she would ever forget the moment Jolinar had entered her, leaving the dying man she had been trying to save. "I am sorry for your loss," she said.

"Thank you." He slowly inclined his head. "Though I suppose, as her last host, you keenly feel her loss as well."

Really? She took a bite or kren to gain some time. “Yes, we weren’t, ah, together for long, but…” She shrugged. ‘Memorable’ would sound trite. ‘Traumatising’ would be harsh, even if it was true. “I won’t ever forget her.” She took a forkful of liso’n while her thoughts raced. Did Tok’ra identify with the gender of their host? It wasn’t something that had come up in the preparations for this mission - a clear oversight, in hindsight. They had no clue how Tok’ra relationships worked, she realised. How did they handle having two beings in one body?

And asking Martouf about it was out of the question - he was clearly grieving his friend. His sad smile as he must remember…

She blinked as more memories rose inside her. Of Martouf. Of… “Lantash?”

His voice changed as the symbiont took over. “You remember. I wasn’t certain since you never said anything.”

“I only just remembered,” she told him. “Her memories are fragmented. Sometimes, I have a… sort of flash.” Likely the result of a trigger. Perhaps she should look into therapy to manage this... No! Therapy would see her benched - the Air Force wasn’t in the habit of trusting people with mental problems in combat. But why hadn’t Lantash introduced themselves earlier?

“But you do remember us,” Lantash said - and reached out, putting his hand on her shoulder.

His touch… she drew a sharp breath as she remembered more. Martouf. Lantash. And… She felt her cheeks flush. They hadn’t been Jolinar’s friends. They had been their *lover*.

“And you remember more,” Lantash said, staring at her, lips twisting into a faint smile.

She nodded a little stiffly. “I am sorry for your loss,” she repeated herself.

“Her memories live on,” he said with another sad smile.

Sam froze for a moment. ‘Her memories’. Not ‘her memory’. Oh, hell! They couldn’t think that she was… She nodded again, more sharply this time - the kren suddenly didn’t taste as well as before.

They couldn’t think that she was somehow Jolinar’s successor - or replacement - could they?

“Everything alright, Carter? Something wrong with the food?”

She turned to face the Colonel, glad - very glad - about the interruption. She really needed a distraction right now. “No, the food’s great, sir. We’ve just been… mourning.”

“Jolinar was our partner,” Martouf said, inclining his head at the Colonel. “It is comforting that part of her lives on in some way, despite the tragic circumstances of how that came to be.”

The Colonel narrowed his eyes, and Sam quickly added: “Fragments of her memories.”

“Ah.” His expression didn’t really change - he was still… suspicious. Of her? No. Of Martouf and Lantash, Sam realised. “Partners?” he asked.

“Lovers. Mates,” Lantash explained.

The Colonel tensed at the change of voice. “I didn’t realise Tok’ra went for such things,” he said with a shrug. “You know, lovers.”

And Lantash frowned in return. “As our hosts do, we as well fall in love.”

“Must be tough, having to share your body and a relationship.”

“Not at all,” Lantash said. Then Martouf continued. “Everything’s shared, Colonel. Between us all.”

“Sounds a bit crowded to me.”

“It would, of course, since you have never experienced it,” Martouf replied.

He was glancing at her, Sam realised with a sinking feeling. Did he expect her to comment on that? The last thing she wanted to do right now was to discuss Tok’ra romance. With anyone.

But the Colonel was staring at her as well.

Before she could even think of what to say to extract herself, a body crashed into the buffet next to them, sending the food flying as the table toppled.

Sam almost cried out in relief at the interruption.

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The Tok’ra Part 5

P34-353J, December 4th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Catra didn’t have too much experience with spies. She only met one, actually, and that was a painful memory. How she had been as stupid as to ever trust Double Trouble… She suppressed the urge to shake her head at her own folly. But she had worked undercover herself, and she knew something about hiding your intentions - she wouldn’t have survived in the Horde if she hadn’t been able to do that.

And in her opinion, Jakar was a smooth operator, to use one of the Earth movie terms, but how he approached the spy halfway into the dinner just didn’t look… quite as natural and inconspicuous as it should have been.

Of course, she knew what this was about, so she might be biased. Maybe. Cordesh didn’t look like he suspected anything, but he was a spy, so he would be good at hiding any reaction. And if he suspected that he was detected, he might trigger whatever he had planned early.

Well, it was up to Jakar now. She was curious how they would handle it, tilting her head a bit to better listen in to the conversation.

“Cordesh! Enjoying the meal?”

“Jakar. Not as much as you must, after your mission.”

“Oh, yes. I did miss kren, especially.”

“Who doesn’t?”

Then Jakar’s voice changed. Mats was talking, then. “So, you finally grew to like it, Firnan?”

Cordesh's voice changed as well. "Yes. It took me a while, but who can resist it?"

Jakar nodded, smiling warmly, and took a bite of mat'o.

But Kordesh tensed up. Something wasn't right. And he was reaching to the small of his back, where…

Catra was already moving, jumping over the table between her and the two spies, when Jakar grabbed Kordesh's arm, and the two started wrestling over a... zat!

Catra unsheathed her claws as she closed. A single swipe, and… No! She had to think of the host! Clenching her teeth, she kicked Cordesh into the back of his knees, sending him to the floor.

But the spy took Jakar with him, turning the whole thing into a throw - and sent Jakar into the buffet.

But Catra was on him already, grabbing both his wrists and pinning him to the ground. He tried to shake her off, but he didn't have enough leverage or strength - not against Catra, at least; he was stronger than a human.

And then Adora was there, and Jakar was back, and the fight was over. Between the three of them, they had Cordesh secured before the rest of the people present made it over. Garshaw looked at them - at Jakar - with narrowed eyes while Jakar stripped him of weapons and tools and everything but his clothes.

"Firnan claimed to have tasted kren before and grown to like it," Jakar told her.

Garshaw nodded as if that was enough to identify a spy.

"You must be really serious about your food," Catra commented with a glance at Jakar.

"Kren is made from local sources," he said. "It's only available on this planet - and Cordesh and Firnan were not stationed here

before they arrived with the councillors.”

Ah. That explained it. Catra nodded.

“Then we need to find out if Cordesh decided to betray us or if he was replaced,” Garshaw said.

Right. Catra was really glad she hadn’t ripped the man’s hand off.

“Will you extract the symbiont?” Daniel asked.

Right, they could do that.

“It’s the most expedient way to check,” Garshaw replied. “As soon as Firnan is free, he can tell us what happened.”

Cordesh scoffed. “The plague that is the Tok’ra will soon be wiped out! And we will crush your allies as well!” he yelled.

Well, Catra might not be an expert on spies, but she knew empty bravado when she saw it. Although… She narrowed her eyes. “Could he have contacted someone in the system with this?” She pointed at the round thing on the ground next to the zat.

“Check it,” Garshaw said.

While another aide picked the thing up, Catra looked at the captured spy. He was clenching his teeth, which she took as a good sign.

“It’s pointless! You are doomed!”

Yeah, definitely empty bravado.

“There wasn’t a long-range transmission since before he arrived here; the cache still holds the data.”

So their secret was still safe. Catra smiled. That was a relief! Losing operational surprise would have been quite the setback.

“But there are short-range transmissions logged. Very little data, though. I’m trying to access…”

“Shor’wai’e! Yas!” Cordesh yelled. “Mal…”

Catra slugged the spy, then held his mouth shut before he could say anything else, but the communicator beeped.

Then the base shook from an explosion.

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Jack O’Neill cursed as he crouched to keep his balance. “Are we under attack?” he snapped, his hand going for his carbine - which had been left in their quarters. He gripped his pistol’s holster instead.

Garshaw was already talking into one of those round communicators. “Melion, what’s going on? Melion?” He saw her press her lips together for a moment before she went on: “Ker’seh? Nelias?” she waited a moment

Jack struggled against the urge to rush out, get his M4 and… what then? Half the Tok’ra in the room had already left.

“We have lost contact with the transporter room,” Garshaw announced.

“I smell smoke,” Catra said. Her nose twitched. “And… burning flesh.” She was still holding the spy’s mouth shut.

Jack winced. “If they took the transporter room, they’ll be storming the base right now.”

“I don’t hear any shooting,” Catra retorted.

Then Per’sus’ voice came through the communicator. “The transporter room has been destroyed. I don’t see any breach in the walls, though.”

That meant it hadn’t been an attack from the outside. Jack muttered another curse. “Sabotage. He must have planted a bomb.”

“More than one, I fear,” the snake holding the spy’s communicator ball said.

“Give it to me!” Anise snapped. “I’ll check.”

She all but ripped the thing out of the other Tok’ra’s hands. He didn’t seem upset, so that was probably normal.

Per’sus spoke up again. “The guards in the transporter room are dead. And the ring transport was damaged and is nonfunctional.”

Which meant they were trapped in the base! Wait, no - they had that tunnel-growing technology. “Can you grow us an exit?” Jack asked.

Garshaw shook her head. “We don’t have the necessary tools in this base. The main base should have recorded the explosion, but it’ll take them a while to reach us.”

Damn. “Didn’t want potential spies getting a glimpse, huh?” Jack asked.

The snake’s grimace was answer enough.

Fortunately, Adora didn’t say anything about trust saving them and distrust hurting them. Instead, she said: “I could restore magic to the planet. Then Glimmer could teleport us out.”

“All of us?” Malinor asked, raising her eyebrows.

“Two at a time,” Glimmer corrected her. “But I think I’ll be able to get everyone out.”

‘I think’, Jack noted. That wasn’t a clear confirmation in his book. “How long will it take for the others to reach us with a tunnel or transporter?”

Another aide whose name he had forgotten replied: “They’ll be here in half an hour - I was just talking to Laran.”

Half an hour? Well, that wasn’t too bad. Jack started to nod.

Then Anise went to Carter and Entrapta and showed them the communicator. “Look at that!”

Jack really didn’t like Carter’s reaction.

“We need the scanner,” she said.

“Yes. If there are more bombs, they should show up on the scanner.” Entrapta nodded.

“More bombs?” Salesh stared at them.

Jack glanced at the captured spy. He couldn’t see the snake’s mouth, but his eyes… the scum was happy.

“OK, let’s see - those bombs can’t be using Naquadah, or we would have found them in our earlier scan, so…” Entrapa trailed off, eyes glued to her scanner.

“Check for these chemicals!” Anise rattled down some formula Jack couldn’t follow.

Carter could, though, which was what counted. “Yes. None of that, none of those, either, but…” She drew a sharp breath through clenched teeth, and Jack knew that shit had just hit the fan - Carter only looked like that when things were about to go really wrong.

“How bad is it?” he asked.

“We have half a dozen bombs with chemical explosives placed throughout the base, sir,” she replied. “And it doesn’t look like the spots were randomly chosen.”

“We’re running a structural analysis,” Entrapta cut in.

“Yes. Our technology makes tunnelling very easy, but without proper structural reinforcements, the tunnels are slightly more vulnerable to shocks,” Anise said.

Jack refrained from closing his eyes. “Don’t tell me - if the bombs go off, we won’t need to be buried after our deaths?” Hell, to die buried alive… getting crushed quickly would be a mercy. He suppressed a shudder.

Carter nodded with a grimace.

“Well, the bombs didn’t go off,” Adora said. “Only one did.”

“But they’re on a timer,” Anise said.

When it rained, it poured. “How much time do we have?”

“Fifteen minutes, sir.”

“It’s evacuation time,” Jack said.

Garshaw nodded.

“Uh…” Adora’s expression made Jack close his eyes and sigh. “If I restore magic, I’ll be… well, I’ll have to use all the magic returning. And we still don’t know what my healing will do to symbionts inside a host.”

And that had all the snakes in the room exchange grim glances.

“Can’t you leave your host temporarily?”

“Only for a very short time without a habitat or stasis unit,” Garshaw said. “And we don’t have either in this base.”

More secrecy messing things up. If Jack were a believer, he’d tell God that this was a little too blatant.

“We’ll have to defuse the bombs then,” Entrapta said. “Before it’s too late.”

“Can you do this?” Garshaw asked.

“We should be able to - and we have about ten minutes before we’ll have to return magic, anyway!” Entrapta told her. “Let’s go! The closest bomb is down the hallway outside!”

She looked excited, Jack saw. At least Carter looked suitably concerned as the geek squad rushed out of the room.

He ran with them - he had a lot of experience in demolitions, and since they were facing chemical bombs instead of some Naquadah or space magic stuff, Jack should be able to help.

And defusing a bomb definitely beat waiting while his friends and teammates risked their lives defusing it, in Jack’s opinion.

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Watching others do their best to save them all - and risk their lives in the process - was torture, in Adora’s opinion.

“Alright, kid, let’s see what kind of anti-tampering mechanism our snake has left for us to trigger. It can’t be something that reacts to mere movement and shock, or it would have gone off when the base shook. But he must have a way to keep us from just pulling the bombs off and dropping them down a spare tunnel.” Jack said. He sounded tense, but neither he nor Bow looked as tense as they should be - they were so close to the first bomb they had found, if it went off, not even Adora could do anything for them!

“According to my scan, there’s a fine mesh inside the outer shell, connected to the detonator. But it’s not perfectly covering everything, see?” Bow showed his pad to Jack.

“That’s to keep us from just shooting or cutting the thing. What about the glue keeping the bomb stuck to the floor here?”

“That’s under a mild current - so, perhaps if we kept the current going somehow…”

“There would still be some change when you pull the bomb off the wall, and if the bomb’s sensitive enough…”

“Boom.”

“Exactly, kid.”

Adora let out a sigh through clenched teeth - softly; you didn’t startle people defusing ordnance; the Horde had been very clear about that. Even Catra hadn’t joked around in those lessons. Or with live ordnance.

She couldn’t do anything here. So she stepped around the corner and checked up on the others. If Entrapta, Sam and Anise managed to crack the communicator, they could turn off all bombs with a single command. Or so they hoped.

“Oh… that’s a very sophisticated protocol! Almost as good as Horde Prime’s! Well, mostly - did you see this here, Sam?”

“Yes. That seems like an obvious weakness. Probably too obvious.”

“Yes! It’s probably a, what do you call it, decoy?”

“That, and an alert, I would say. But I think we can circumvent it like this…”

“Yes,” Anise cut in. “And that should get us past the encryption to send out the delay command to the bombs. But we still need to figure out the command.”

“How much longer until you have to restore magic?” Garshaw asked as Adora stepped back from Entrapta, Sam and Anise to check on the others.

“Seven more minutes,” Adora replied after a check of her watch. Then she’d have two minutes left to use all the magic surging through her and… try not to expel the symbionts while Glimmer teleported people out.

“That’s cutting it close,” Garshaw commented.

Adora looked at her. The Tok’ra leader seemed to be, well, focused on her instead of the people defusing the bomb. “We really don’t want to risk accidentally killing you all with my healing magic,” she said. Hadn’t she explained that before?

“But the risk for you and your friends would be lesser.”

Oh. “That’s not how we do things,” Adora said, frowning despite herself. What did Garshaw think she was, so selfish as to sacrifice others for her?

And now Garshaw was smiling at her. Had that been a test? Adora wasn’t fond of such games - Shadow Weaver had liked them.

Malinor spoke up: “Can you use your magic powers to seal off or disable the bombs?”

Adora bit her lower lip. “I have never done that before,” she admitted. “I could attempt to turn them into plants, but if they are as sensitive to defusing attempts as it sounds they are, they might detonate anyway.” Before she managed to figure out how to repeat what she had done to Horde Prime’s flagship. Or how to freeze anything in stasis, or something. She wasn’t a sorceress! She hadn’t studied magic! Or tried to use her magic for such things.

Glimmer would be able to do that. Probably. Adora glanced at her friend. She looked tense but determined. Stubborn, almost scowling, as she watched Bow and Jack work around the corner.

“Six minutes left.”

They were timing her? Adora looked at the Tok’ra who had spoken, Salesh. Oh, of course, they would be watching the clock count down. Their lives were at stake, after all.

“If we start teleporting out, we’ll leave the spy for last,” Catra said. She sounded matter-of-factly, almost calm, but Adora could

see her tail twitching - her lover was as nervous as she felt herself.

Adora frowned at her, and Catra shrugged. "If Glimmer exhausts herself…"

Adora understood the sentiment, but… "She'd still do everything to save Firnan."

Catra sighed. "Right." Her ears drooped. She was probably blaming herself for forgetting about the host taken over by the spy.

Adora smiled softly. No one was perfect. But Catra was doing so much better than… before.

"Five minutes left."

"How are Jack and Bow doing?" Adora asked in a low voice.

"They want to cut out the piece of wall with the bomb stuck to it," Catra said. "But it's a crystal, and so if they cut through it, it'll send a power surge through the adhesive. Bow's trying to rig up a surge compensator or something."

Adora nodded. "And I can cut through the crystal." She summoned her sword. Again.

And she could carry the bomb away quickly. She might not get all of them, but enough so the base wouldn't collapse completely should be possible.

"Don't do anything stupid. We only need to deal with half of them," Catra said.

She didn't try to keep Adora from doing it, though. Adora reached out and pulled her into her arms, just holding her for a few seconds. Feeling her warmth against her body, Feeling Catra tense up, squirming for just a moment, before relaxing into her embrace. Yes…

“Four minutes.”

Rats.

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Four minutes left. Samantha Carter pressed her lips together. Four minutes until Adora would restore magic, and Glimmer would start teleporting people out. And until Adora might accidentally kill every Tok’ra with some uncontrolled mass-healing magic.

Which also meant six minutes until the bombs would go off and cause the entire base to collapse. Perhaps the Tok’ra’s tunnel-growing technology had some drawbacks as well - though Sam hadn’t done the static calculations to know if this was because of the inherent weakness of their technology Garshaw had mentioned or if the bombs would wreck a conventionally-built base as well.

And she didn’t have the time to get distracted right now. They were so close to cracking the signal to shut down all the bombs!

“Nothing in the cache - the main unit clears it right after use,” Anise said.

“That would almost make it redundant, wouldn’t it?” Entrapta commented. “Oh! Nothing in the transmitter, either - nothing that wasn’t already logged.”

And the log files had been the first thing they had checked. That left the main unit’s memory. Which was not only heavily encrypted but also using a sort of proprietary operating system that none of them - not even Anise, who had the most experience with Goa’uld communications amongst them - had ever seen.

But it still used familiar principles. And known hardware with which it interacted.

And that opened ways to crack it.

“Three minutes!”

Goa’uld communicators were a mature technology - but they weren’t perfect. And this was a modified communicator - whoever had sent the spy had taken care to hide additional capacities inside it. New technology. Not as tested and proven.

And they had taken shortcuts when installing it.

Sam smiled when she found a minor glitch in the program controlling the interface between the main unit and the transmitter. “Anise? Take a look at that.”

“Oh, yes!” The Tok’ra smiled and started typing on her tool.

“Oh! Clever!” Entrapta’s hair flew over her own multitool. “If we overload the cache here…”

“...it will access the main unit’s cache,” Sam finished. And they could use that to insert a program to download the cache.

“Done!” Anise announced.

“Yes!” Sam quickly ran a search - and came up empty. But the communicator controlled the bombs, so the code to stop or at least delay the detonations had to be in there! The spy had used it to detonate the bomb in the transporter room!

Sam blinked. With a verbal command. A verbal code.

“I’m so stupid!” she snapped. “There’s no code in the communicator because they never saved it in there - they only memorised it!”

“Oh!” Entrapta’s eyes widened. “That’s clever!”

Anise cursed.

And Sam whirled around. “But the codes have to be in the bombs!” And the Colonel and Bow were working on one around

the corner!

“Yes!”

“What?” Adora stared at them, but Sam, followed by Entrapta and Anise, rushed past the woman.

He was looking at her as she rounded the corner - he would have heard her running. Good - she hadn’t distracted him at a critical moment. “Sir, we need access to the bomb’s communicator,” she said as calmly as she could.

After a fraction of a second, he nodded. “That might be a little tricky.”

“Here’s the probe!” Entrapta handed him a thin needle-like device. “It transmits wirelessly. Just touch the communication array.”

He turned to Bow. “We’ll need to insert it through the internal mesh. Without touching it.”

“Two minutes!”

Bow looked grim but nodded as well.

“Bow!” someone - Glimmer - said behind them.

But the boy had already turned to face the bomb, kneeling down. “I can guide you with my scanner.”

“Let’s do it.”

And Sam was forced to wait and stare as the two men started working.

“Alright… this is the spot. Now… align the drill… bit more to the right, the angle is… yes, like that.”

The Colonel had sweat on his brow now. “Step back into cover!” he snapped. In a soft voice that only Sam, Bow and probably Catra heard, he added: “Just in case.”

Sam wanted to stay, but that wouldn't have made sense.

She still hated herself for obeying and getting into cover around the corner and behind Emily's shield.

"Alright, here we go!"

"Steady, steady… Stop!"

"And now the probe…"

"Check the angle."

"Yes, yes…"

"O-One minute!"

Sam held her breath.

"And… Done! We've got the thingie in!" the Colonel announced.

"We've got contact!" Entrapta blurted out.

Sam was already diving into the bomb's memory. Detonation protocol, communication… "There!" She blinked. "Hal mek?" That meant 'hold' in Goa'uld. It couldn't be so easy, could it?

"Sent!" Anise announced.

"Zero!" the aide announced.

A moment later, Anise yelled. "Bombs delayed!"

A cheer went up.

And Sam took a deep breath and sat down, leaning back against the wall.

That had been a little too close for her taste. And to think she had missed the possibility that the communicator didn't hold the codes to disarm or delay the bombs! Even though it made so much

sense - it would ensure that no one could stop the bombs without the spy's cooperation.

But they had solved the problem, which was what counted.

"Oh, here's the command to disarm the bombs, 'hol'!" Entrapta said.

That meant 'stop' in Goa'uld. The spy probably had picked common terms they could slip into any sentence so they could use them in the open without sounding suspicious. Something to keep in mind.

Sam sighed as she got up and stretched. Anise and Entrapta were sending the commands to disarm the bombs, and Glimmer was both hugging and scolding Bow.

"That was cutting it a bit close, Captain."

She looked at the Colonel. He was smiling, teasing her. She wanted to hug him. Instead, she nodded with a grin. "That's how such projects go, sir. There's always a crunch at the end."

She couldn't tell if he got the comment about programming tasks. But his smile turned a little softer. "Good work, Captain!"

"Thank you, sir."

*****

Catra let out a relieved sigh - silently; she had a reputation to maintain - and let her tail trail over Adora's thigh as she turned back to look at the captured spy, who was still on the ground, glaring at her over his gag. Grinning, she crouched down and looked him straight in the eyes. "So… looks like you were clever but not clever enough."

He made some angry noises through the gag.

“Don’t bother; my friends are thorough - you won’t be able to detonate the bombs now, even if you had a communicator.” Well, between the four of them, they shouldn’t have missed that possibility. She still said it loudly enough, just in case they had missed it and were listening. Well, not Bow - he was too busy dealing with Glimmer trying to kiss and throttle him at the same time.

The spy seemed to agree with her, though, and switched to silently glaring at her.

She sighed again, but theatrically now. “Let me guess - more threats about how your masters will surely crush us, how we are doomed, how the Empire will prevail?” She shook her head. “It won’t happen; trust me - I’ve been there.” And said the same things. “You’ll see.”

“No, they won’t,” one of the Tok’ra guarding the spy - another aide - said.

Catra narrowed her eyes. Did they mean…?

“What?” Adora butted in.

“When we captured Goa’uld, we extract from their host and execute them for their crimes,” Per’sus explained.

“You can’t do that!” Adora blurted out. “They’re a prisoner!”

“They’re Goa’uld!” Per’sus retorted.

“They’re a captured spy.” And O’Neill had decided to stop watching Sam disassemble the communicator and join the discussion. “We shoot spies back home.”

Adora stared at him. “But… they’re a prisoner. They can’t hurt anyone any more.”

“They’re Goa’uld,” Per’sus said. “They need to pay for their crimes.”

“They almost managed to kill us all,” Garshaw spoke up. “And they most certainly killed Cordesh - the Goa’uld murder every Tok’ra they can capture. Usually by torture.”

“It’s a risk every one of us faces,” Jakar added.

Adora stared at them for a moment, looking from one to the other. Then she raised her chin a little, and her expression grew stubborn. “That doesn’t make it right to kill them when they’re a helpless prisoner!”

“We don’t even know if they murdered your spy,” Catra pointed out in support of her lover. “And killing prisoners means you can’t get any information out of them.” Adora pouted at her for that addition, but Catra shrugged - the Tok’ra struck her as pragmatic.

“That would require us to sacrifice a host to them. We won’t do that,” Garshaw said. “And putting them in stasis would not functionally change their fate - without a host, they would remain in stasis forever.”

“You could put them into animals,” Adora suggested.

“Or into a habitat made for the symbionts!” Entrapta added.

That, on the other hand, seemed to shock the Tok’ra. And the spy looked genuinely frightened for the first time since they had captured them, Catra noticed.

“Animals?” Gashaw repeated. “But that would…” She shook her head.

“We’ve encountered a Goa’uld possessing a large predator,” Sam told them.

“But to bond with an animal!” Per’sus blurted out. “That’s… the mental contamination from that - you’d lose your mind!”

“The snake seemed smart enough to give us some trouble,” O’Neill said. “I should know.”

“It’s an abomination!” Salesh stated. “To bond with an animal is a fate worse than death - far worse. We wouldn’t subject even a Goa’uld to that.”

“They must have been utterly desperate - and likely not of sound mind already - to do this.” Per’sus looked like he wanted to spit.

Catra didn’t think this was a good moment to mention that they had been discussing letting the captured Goa’uld possess animal bodies.

“But we could let them into a habitat,” Entrapta said. “We have two captured Goa’uld in such habitats, and they are doing fine.”

“As far as we can tell,” Sam added. “At least they have not complained.”

“You have captured Goa’uld? And you’re holding them in… a habitat?” Garshaw asked.

“Like a fish tank but for snakes,” O’Neill told them.

“Osiris and Setesh. We captured them on Earth,” Daniel said. “They were left there when Ra left.”

“We know of those System Lords,” Garshaw spat. “Even millennia after their disappearance, their crimes are not forgotten!”

Catra managed not to comment about holding long grudges. But it was a near thing, even though she understood the sentiment. But she also knew how bad holding such grudges was for you.

“And you haven’t executed them as spies?” Per’sus asked O’Neill.

“Well, you know…” O’Neill shrugged. “Their circumstances were a little different from theirs.” He nodded at the spy on the ground.

“We recovered Osiris from a stasis jar,” Sam explained. “Although it could be argued that Setesh was infiltrating Earth society when we caught him.”

“You are very soft for someone claiming to wage war against the Goa’uld,” Garshaw said.

“Even if we were willing to kill prisoners, it makes no sense to do it,” Glimmer said. “They can provide valuable information, and if the enemy knows they won’t be killed, they are more likely to surrender.”

“But to put them into a habitat…” Per’sus shook his head. “Like a larva. Without a partner to bond to, to share your thoughts and memories…” He seemed to suppress a shudder.

“They are fed three meals a day and got a warm place to sleep,” O’Neill said.

“And we built them a keyboard - keyboards - to communicate with us!” Entrapta piped up with a smile. “Sized for Goa’uld!”

“It’s still… We need hosts. To live without one is… like living as a cripple.”

“With brain damage,” Anise added.

The Goa’uld suppressed their hosts, as far as Catra knew. But they also got access to their memories. Was that more important than merely a source of information?

“Oh.” Entrapta looked surprised. “But if it’s so bad, why haven’t they said anything?”

“They probably think the alternative is execution,” Catra told her friend.

“Oh.”

Adora nodded. “If that’s how it is, then we need to find a better solution.”

It was clear from the expressions on the Tok’ra what alternative solution they would favour.

Well, good luck trying to convince Adora of that! Catra thought.

*****

And here he had thought they could get a good cop/bad cop thing going. But it seemed that the good cops, while meaning well, had unknowingly terrified the spy more than the ones wanting to execute him. Jack O'Neill faintly smiled at the irony - and made a mental note of the fact that the spy apparently was more terrified of being put into an animal than of being executed. That was important information. Also important was that the habitats they had built for their prisoners apparently qualified as cruel and unusual punishment. And, of course, that the snakes they had captured hadn't complained.

But that was for future analysis. They had a more urgent problem to deal with. "How about we discuss what to do with the spy after we've interrogated him?" he suggested.

"We need to liberate Finran," Garshaw said. "He'll be able to tell us what the spy did while in his body."

Jack suppressed the urge to say that they shouldn't discuss this in front of the spy. The snake would already know such obvious information.

"And that would kill the Goa'uld. Eventually," Catra said. "Unless you've got a stasis pod or a habitat."

"One that we could spare," Garshaw agreed.

"We can build a habitat!" Entrapta said at once. "I mean… it might not be as nice as I thought it would be - they really should've told me that! - but it's better than being killed, right?"

Jack couldn't tell if she was honestly asking or if that was a rhetorical question. But she was correct.

"Yes," Adora said. "We can take them back to Earth and keep them there."

The snakes didn’t like that - they exchanged a few significant glances. “We need to be able to interrogate them,” Garshaw said. “We’ll be able to see through their lies.”

Implying that Stargate Command wouldn’t. But they were right in that they likely knew more about how the Goa’uld worked - hell, about the Goa’uld, period - that would make it harder for the spy to lie or hide information. “We can interrogate them here,” Jack said. That might ruffle some feathers back home, but fewer than if he had just invited the snakes to set up an interrogation room in Stargate Command. Even though it would have been funny to see how the spooks with their foreign torture chambers would react to aliens pulling their own moves on them.

“As long as Finran doesn’t have to suffer for too much longer,” Per’sus said. He turned to stare at the spy. “It goes without saying that, should Finran die, we will not show you any mercy.”

“And our prospective allies just have shown us that there are indeed worse fates than death,” Malinor added with an expression that made Jack wince a little.

Yeah, those snakes really hated the Goa’uld.

“OK! It shouldn’t take too long - we know how to build one. We probably should build a few more in reserve.” Entrapta nodded. “Or a lot if we are going to invade a planet.”

“But we also need to find a more humane way to keep Goa’uld prisoners,” Glimmer said.

Garshaw smiled sadly at that. “I sincerely hope you find a solution, though we have tried to find alternatives for millennia since there are so few voluntary hosts, and none of the proposed solutions was practicable or morally acceptable.”

“What about artificial bodies?” Entrapta apparently took that as a challenge.

“That wouldn’t satisfy our need for a partner,” Per’sus explained with a gentler smile. “It would be like a more mobile version of your ‘habitats’, I believe.”

“Oh. I guess that means cloned bodies without higher cerebral functions are also out.”

Once more, the Tok’ra shuddered - and the spy looked frightened again.

“That might satisfy some of the biological needs of our species with regards to mental capacity,” Anise said, “but it would leave us bereft of the emotional and intellectual benefits a host offers.”

“It would be like inhabiting a corpse.” Malinor shook her head.

“You need a sapient, sentient partner,” Daniel said, nodding. “But the Goa’uld keep their hosts’ consciousness suppressed, trapped in their own body. Do they have different needs?”

Once more, the Tok’ra exchanged glances before Per’sus replied: “They have perverted this. They thrive on the control, on the oppression of their host. And that reflects on their entire society.”

Daniel’s eyes widened. “That explains so much!” he exclaimed. “If there is a biological urge, beyond genetic memory, then we have to reexamine our views of Goa’uld society!”

“But if it’s a perverted urge, it also means they can change,” Glimmer pointed out.

“Some of us can,” Garshaw agreed. “But few amongst the Goa’uld can overcome their… condition.”

“Or their conditioning,” Daniel said. “If this is like… We need to talk about this with psychologists. It might be treatable.”

He made the snakes sound like a bunch of poor, sick patients. Or addicts. Jack pressed his lips together so he wouldn’t sneer. They were monsters. Monsters who apparently had a choice to be

decent people and rejected it. But that was a topic for another day. They had a more urgent situation to deal with. "Anyway, let's get a habitat so we can start interrogating our spy," he said.

"And in the meantime, while we restore the transporter, we can continue our discussions," Garshaw said.

"As long as we can get more food," Catra cut in. "I, at least, wasn't finished with my dinner," she added when Adora frowned at her.

Jack chuckled at that - he could do with some more food himself. Even if it was snake meat.

*****

The food didn't taste as good as before. At least to Adora. The thought that they were torturing their prisoners… She shook her head. How could this have happened? Why hadn't their prisoners said anything? Did they really fear they would be killed if they complained?

She bit down on a piece of fried meat, chewed twice then swallowed it. With some difficulty.

"Careful. You don't want to choke," Catra told her - in between stuffing her own mouth with more fried fish than should fit.

Adora frowned at her. "I'm not going to choke."

"But you're blaming yourself for the Goa'uld's problems." Catra twitched her shoulders in that not-quite-shrug of hers.

"No," Adora protested. "I'm just… wondering how this could happen." They had done all they could to treat their prisoners well - or so they thought.

"Because we don't know as much as we thought we do about the Goa'uld?" Catra shrugged again. "That kind of stuff happens. Nobody's perfect."

Adora pressed her lips together. That was true, but… "That sounds a bit callous," she said.

"Yeah." Catra agreed. "So?"

"What?"

"We did what we thought was best," Catra explained. "It turned out we were wrong. Kind of - no one seems to have a better solution, anyway. So… why torture yourself over it?"

"Because we have to do better!" Adora took a deep breath. "We need to fix our mistake." They couldn't torture their prisoners.

"If there's a way to fix it," her lover said. "You can't fix everything." She narrowed her eyes at Adora. "Not even She-Ra can do that."

Well, she should! But Adora didn't say that out loud. Her friends would scold her for that. And they were right - she didn't like it, but she knew she couldn't solve every problem. She couldn't heal everyone on Earth. She knew it well enough.

But she hated it all the same.

"And the Tok'ra have been working on this for a long time," Catra pointed out. "Not to help the Goa'uld, but to get an alternative to needing hosts, but it works out to the same."

Only, it didn't work out at all in this case. "There has to be a way to fix this," Adora said. "Entrapta and the others will find it."

"They've got other things to do. More important things," Catra retorted.

Adora was aware of that as well. Of course, they couldn't just focus on how to treat prisoners when they were fighting a war. But… "It would be easier to make the Goa'uld surrender if we had an alternative." Like with the Horde.

“They would have to believe us in the first place,” Catra said. “Remember what we were told about the princesses?”

Of course, she did! Adora pressed her lips together. The Goa’uld would expect the worst. Not without justification - the Tok’ra apparently had been killing all their prisoners for thousands of years. To free their hosts, and because they had no alternative, apparently, but still.

The war would be worse than they had expected, she realised. Harder. Bloodier.

“We need a way to fix this,” she repeated herself. Some way to show the Goa’uld that there was an alternative to enslaving others.

But as much as she tried, she couldn’t think of any at the moment. She could only hope that their friends would think of one.

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The Tok’ra Part 6

Chapter 61: The Tok’ra Part 6

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 4th, 1998

“...and then we returned through the Stargate to prepare a habitat and report while Queen Glimmer, Princess Adora, Colonel O’Neill, Daniel, Bow, Teal’c and Catra stayed to continue their discussions with the Tok’ra, sir.” Samantha Carter stood at ease as she delivered her verbal report to Stargate’s Command Council.

“And you didn’t ask them to remove the parasite in Lieutenant Lenkova?” Sidorov asked with a deep frown.

“Since we confirmed that the Tok’ra can remove a Goa’ld from their host without harming either, I am certain that this will be amongst the topics being discussed right now, General,” Sam told him.

“Yeah!” Entrapta chimed in, nodding emphatically. “Adora and the others would never forget about her. Although if we can analyse how the Tok’ra are doing it when they extract the Goa’uld from Finran, we might be able to copy the method and do it ourselves. I hope they wait for us before they continue.”

“They won’t start until we have the habitat ready,” Sam reassured her friend. They had an agreement about that, after all, and after SG-1 and the Etherians had been instrumental in saving the base and the Tok’ra High Council, Sam doubted that the Tok’ra would break it just to kill a Goa’uld. Though, as experience had taught, you could never be really certain when it came to aliens. “And, speaking of habitats…” Sam looked at General Hammond.

“Go on, Captain.”

“It seems that both Goa’uld and Tok’ra have biological and psychological requirements that we weren’t aware of so far, sir.

Biologically, they need sapient hosts. Without one, their intellectual capacity is diminished to some degree. And they also seem to have a deep psychological need for a sapient host, though we haven't been able to confirm that."

"Ah." the General nodded. "That complicates things."

General Haig nodded in agreement, though Sidorov looked confused. Sam couldn't tell if the Russian didn't understand what she had just explained - or if he did but didn't understand why they thought accidentally lobotomising prisoners was a problem. She also wasn't sure which would be worse.

"Yes!" Entrapta chimed in. "We need to find a better way to keep Goa'uld prisoners. But we haven't found one yet."

Nor had the Tok'ra.

"Understood." General Haig nodded. "In that case, best expedite the construction of the habitat - and make another one for the Goa'uld in Lieutenant Lenkova."

Sidorov scoffed. "You volunteered Stargate Command as a prison for Goa'uld?"

"No, General," Sam told him. "But since the Tok'ra would kill the prisoner, the Alliance has to take them off their hands. Stargate Command would be suitable since we already hold two such prisoners, but the decision whether or not the spy will be imprisoned here as well is up to the Command Council."

"If you don't want them, we'll take them," Entrapta chimed in as Sam had hoped. "We can house them in a ship. Or construct an orbital prison. Or maybe place the prison on an asteroid."

"I was just checking that you did not exceed your orders, Captain," the Russian spat. "You do not speak for Earth or Stargate Command. That you engage in diplomacy is questionable in itself."

"We did not exceed our orders," Sam retorted, tensing up. "We represented Stargate Command as per our briefings."

Entrapta cocked her head. "And you can't really prevent Glimmer from speaking for the Alliance - either one. I don't think so. Although your organisation is sometimes a little confusing."

"I'm certain General Sidorov was merely voicing his concerns over Stargate Command's involvement in this," General Haig said. "Everyone here is aware that Stargate Command has no authority over the Alliance."

"Yes," General Hammond agreed. "But we should hold you up any longer. The sooner you have those habitats ready, the sooner you can free this Tok'ra and Lieutenant Lenkova."

Not even Sidorov could say anything against that. But it was clear he wanted to, anyway.

Sam kept her expression neutral, though, until they had left the briefing room and were headed back to her lab.

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P34-353J, December 4th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...so, while we hope you'll find a way to solve our dependency on voluntary hosts, I don't think it's too pessimistic to assume such a solution will not manifest within the next few years - years which will be spent waging an offensive war. If we are to take a more active and open part in this war, we need more hosts."

Catra refrained from rolling her eyes at Garshaw's words. The Tok'ra were fixated on hosts. Understandably, somewhat - if Catra needed a host so she wouldn't lose her mind, she'd certainly focus on that as well. But this was the tenth time or so they mentioned it - they sounded like a broken record, as the humans from Earth would say. Though Catra still didn't get how a broken record could still work.

But they were here to form an alliance - well, to lay the groundwork for one since they couldn't form an alliance by themselves without making Earth mad - and so Catra kept smiling. And if her smile showed her fangs prominently, well, no one had complained so far.

"Speaking of hosts…" Daniel adjusted his glasses. "You must have a lot of people waiting for a host - do you keep them all in stasis?"

After the slightest hesitation, Garshaw nodded.

"You must have a lot of stasis jars," O'Neill commented.

"Yes," Per'sus said. "The alternative would be to let those amongst us who do not have a host suffer. And that is unacceptable."

Catra could respect that. Even if this must be a huge drain on their resources. On the other hand, if they had some crystal device that could grow stasis jars like they could grow tunnels, it wouldn't really cost them much - if a stasis jar could hold a Goa'uld on Earth for thousands of years, a few decades of them underwater, without anyone checking it, they wouldn't require a lot of maintenance.

"Of course," Glimmer said. "You can't let children suffer. Or anyone else."

Garshaw nodded again, but Catra couldn't help feeling that they were hiding something. But what?

"How do you raise your larvae without Jaffa?" Teal'c asked. The big guy had been mostly silent ever since they had set foot on the planet, so this had to be an important question.

Even though it was obvious that the Goa'uld must have been able to raise their children without Jaffa since they had created them.

"That is classified. We can revisit that once we have an alliance. But this touches on some of our most important secrets," Garshaw

said - without looking directly at Teal'c; they were addressing O'Neill, Glimmer and Adora.

"You mean your queen, right?" Daniel blurted out, then winced. "I'm sorry - I know I shouldn't pry."

Garshaw nodded once more, but Daniel had been correct - Catra had caught how they had tensed up.

"So that's why the spy didn't fake an emergency and get out after setting the bombs to explode a minute after he left!" O'Neill exclaimed. He grinned. "He was after your queen - and he didn't want to abandon that mission to kill us until he knew more about us."

Yeah, O'Neill had nailed it. Catra nodded in agreement - a lot made sense now. "You must be keeping your queen isolated from your spies, so one captured operative doesn't spill the secret." Anything else would be… well, even Kyle would realise how stupid it would be to risk your biggest secret with every spy you sent out. Though that meant the queen would only ever meet a few of the Tok'ra. That would be quite lonely. For everyone else, she might as well not… Oh. Catra grinned with more confidence than she felt. "Unless, of course, that's just a smokescreen to ensure that any spy who manages to infiltrate you keeps chasing after a queen who doesn't exist."

All of the Tok'ra High Council tensed up and exchanged glances. And the aides looked confused and then worried for a moment before everyone was all smooth snake-like again.

"We can neither confirm nor deny this," Garshaw said.

But Catra was sure that she was right. The Tok'ra didn't have a queen hidden somewhere.

Before she managed to decide how that changed things, with the Alliance and the war, an aide cocked their head to the side and pulled out a communicator.

"The others have returned with the habitat."

Garshaw smiled. "We can proceed with liberating Finrar then."

And conveniently avoid the current subject, Catra thought.

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The snakes were definitely hiding something - spooks always did; Jack O'Neill knew that from personal experience. Extensive personal experience. And the snakes were all spooks. But this particular secret seemed to go beyond the usual 'that's need to know, and you don't need to know' spiel. It could be a double-bluff, of course. Jack didn't know those snakes very well, after all. But after today's negotiations, dinner and bomb threat… He was pretty sure that they didn't have a queen stashed somewhere.

Not a hundred per cent sure, though. But he wouldn't have to lead the actual alliance negotiations anyway. What the diplomats and spooks did with his report wasn't his problem. And, unlike when writing reports about the Etherians, he didn't have any reason to feel guilty about this, either, he added to himself with a smile as he followed the snakes and Etherians out of the room.

And now he got to see a snake being removed from their host. If that worked… He glanced at Daniel. His friend looked… well, Jack had rarely seen him with such hope in his expression.

"If this works…" Daniel muttered.

"Yes," Jack told him.

If the Tok'ra could save a host, then they could save his wife, Sha're. SG-1 would have to find her and then capture her first, of course, but that was a problem Jack was sure they could manage. Somehow. Probably with the help of the Etherians - not that Jack thought he could keep them away even if he wanted to. And they would likely need the Tok'ra's support as well, if only for the intel.

In fact, it would probably be best if the Etherians took the lead on this - at least officially. SG-1's new management might not think Sha're was worth the risks SG-1 would have to take for such a rescue. Hell, Hammond would likely have vetoed any rescue mission as well if he were in charge - but he would have looked the other way and wouldn't have investigated very deeply if SG-1 managed to 'stumble' onto Sha're on a 'routine exploration mission'. That bastard Russian would want to send them to a gulag for such a stunt, though, and Jack didn't think Haig or Petit would be pleased either. Insubordination tended to make generals angry.

But if Queen Glimmer proposed a rescue mission? There might be some protests from some people, but in the end, the Etherians would get their way. Jack didn't always agree with their priorities, and he certainly was no Marine, but 'no friend left behind' was a fine rule to live by.

They met Carter and Entrapta halfway to the room serving as a holding cell - freshly grown, apparently. "That's just a transport container," Entrapta said, her hair holding up a cat-carrier-sized tank. "The habitat is much bigger, so we left it on Earth."

"Ah." Garshaw nodded, though Jack couldn't help feeling as if the snake wouldn't have been bothered if the tank was the habitat - they really didn't like the Goa'uld. A few millennia of war to the knife would do that to anyone, of course - Jack knew a few conflicts on Earth with that kind of hatred after a few decades.

They continued down the hallway, past two guards. Two more stood outside the cell. And another two were inside, next to the bound and gagged snake. Jack approved, though it felt a bit like they were overcompensating for their earlier lapse - they really should have caught the bombs being placed. But then, this was a decoy base with a skeleton crew. If they had been in their main base on the planet, things might have gone differently. Might.

The spy was unconscious - and strapped on a table, facing some device mounted above him. This wasn't just a holding cell, Jack

realised - this was where they would extract the snake.

Entrapta blinked. “Oh. Are they sedated? Will they need special treatment?”

“They’re in stasis, so they cannot kill Finran,” Anise explained. “But it’s a field, not a chemical, so they will wake up as soon as they leave the fields’ boundaries - or the stasis generator is turned off. They won’t be harmed or killed by this.”

“Much nicer than what they deserve,” Per’sus snarled.

Well, that snake wanted the Goa’uld dead.

“Wouldn’t sedating them be safer?” Glimmer asked.

“Yes,” Garshaw told her. “But if we capture a Goa’uld, we want them to be conscious when we execute them for their crimes.”

“Oh.” All the Etherians - even Catra - seemed to be taken aback by this.

But Jack understood the snakes’ view here. And, to his surprise, Daniel seemed to nod in agreement.

Not the Etherians, though. “Well, we’re not going to execute them!” Adora said.

“So, how do you extract them?” Entrapta had recovered. “Surgically?”

“Yes. We have a precision extractor,” Anise held up a device. “It extracts the symbiont and stores them in this capsule.”

“Is it an automated process?” Cater asked.

“Semi-automatic. It still requires an experienced operator,” Anise replied.

Which would mean the Tok’ra would keep a monopoly on the procedure, at least for the near future.

“Usually, we have a ceremony,” Hen’ru explained. “We list their crimes, then extract them. It can take a long time for the older Goa’uld. Then they can speak their last words, and we kill them.”

“We’re not going to kill them,” Adora repeated herself.

“Yes.” Hen’ru didn’t quite sneer, but he sounded very unhappy.

Not as unhappy as the Goa’uld would soon be, though, Jack thought with a grin as Anise started the device.

He lost his grin a few seconds later, though, when the process began. That was… “Carter,” he whispered, “make a note - after we investigate George Lucas for alien contacts, we’ll investigate Paul Verhoeven.”

“Sir?”

He didn’t have to glance at her to know her expression. She always had the same when he surprised her. “That’s like in Total Recall.” Just with lasers and a needle. He suppressed a shudder as a symbiont was dragged out through a needle that seemed much too small to actually let it pass through.

“Oh! Is that a teleportation effect?” Entrapta blurted out. “Contact-based short-range teleport? For greater precision than a contactless scanner?”

“That’s possible,” Carter replied. “I don’t think a Goa’uld symbiont could be compressed enough to pass through a syringe of that size without dying in the process. They are vertebrates, not invertebrates.”

“Their bones would be crushed, yes,” Entrapta agreed. “You could reconstitute them, in theory, but I think it would be fatal. Probably.”

Jack suppressed a shudder and hoped that they didn’t propose testing that.

“And the way a symbiont attaches themselves to the host’s central nervous system, a contact-based scan might offer greater precision - and might also suppress the release of the symbiont toxin.”

That sounded logical to Jack. Of course, Carter was almost always correct about such things.

Anise pulled the tube attached to the mechanism off and held it up, then ran a scanner over it. “The Goa’uld survived the extraction,” she said after a green light went on on her device.

“Great!” Entrapta stepped forward, holding up her snake carrier. “It got an adaptive valve - just put the end with the opening in here… the container has an opening, right? Or do you teleport the symbiont in and out?”

“We usually smash the tube,” Per’sus said.

“Oh, right. But isn’t that wasteful?” Entrapta tilted her head with a confused expression. “A perfectly fine container… is it a security precaution?”

“It’s a symbolic gesture,” Per’sus said.

“Ah!” Entrapta nodded. “Like smashing glass, which some Earth cultures do at ceremonies.”

“Err… yes.”

“So… does it open?”

“Yes,” Anise said. “The extractor can also be used in case we have to take out one of our own for a medical reason.”

“Ah. So… let’s do it!”

The tube with the wriggling snake was out on top of the tank, and a sucking noise later, the snake was in the tank, swimming around.

And the former host started sobbing.

*****

"I couldn't do anything… they took Cordesh… and…"

Adora winced - Finran sounded… well, he seemed devastated as two of the guards led him to a seat.

"The Goa'uld *took* Cordesh?" Garshaw asked, narrowing her eyes.

"Yes." Finran sat down, shivering - wrapping his arms around himself. "There was a Goa'uld, Kryse, and she was… in Rosha!"

Several Tok'ra gasped. And Sam did, too.

"They know how to extract symbionts?" Anise asked.

"Yes."

"Who is Rosha?" Glimmer asked.

"She was Jolinar's host," Per'sus said.

She was the Goa'uld who had been in Sam's body. "So… they have Jolinar's knowledge?"

"Yes." Garshaw nodded with a grim expression. "That is… a serious setback."

"Are your bases at risk?"

"Our operatives don't know all our bases - only their own," Garish said. "But Rosha was Jolinar's partner for a long time. The Goa'uld now know a lot about our technology and, more importantly, our tactics."

"Time to change them, then," Catra said. She sounded serious, but the way her tail twitched… Adora suppressed a sigh. Sure, this was an argument for the Tok'ra to change their plans and join the

Alliance, but no one liked being told to change what they were doing.

And indeed, the Tok'ra didn't look happy as they took Finran to another room to debrief him.

"So… before we take the spy back to Earth…" Adora smiled at the Tok'ra. "Can I heal your friend? The one who was sick, you said." She couldn't do anything about Finran - that kind of pain She-Ra's magic couldn't cure.

"Saroosh, yes. Selmak's host." Garshaw nodded, and Adora saw her relax slightly. Good. They needed to show the Tok'ra that allying with Etheria and Earth was best for everyone.

"Can we meet them?"

"We'll bring her here." Garshaw looked at her aide, who used their communicator.

"Saroosh is very old, which has aggravated her condition," Per'sus said. "Age catches up with everyone - we can grant our hosts our longevity, but only to a point."

No matter - Adora could help with that. As Jack had proven.

But when Saroosh arrived, about twenty minutes later, on a cot, Adora had second thoughts. The woman looked so frail… And so old. Not like Madame Razz, who was a thousand years old but still spry. Saroosh looked like she could die at any moment. She-Ra would have healed her on the spot, but Selmak was still inside her.

"So, you're the one who has offered to heal Saroosh." Ah, that was Selmak speaking.

Adora nodded. "Yes. I can heal everyone."

"But you're not sure if I would be expelled - or killed - by your magic."

“Yes.”

Selmak laughed. Softly, and ending in a coughing fit. “That sounds like magic. I remember it.”

“Oh?” Glimmer cocked her head.

“I saw a few… magicians?” Selmak squinted.

“We call them sorcerers. Or witches,” Glimmer told him.

“Yes. I saw them do magic. But they couldn’t heal.”

“They probably never learned it. But She-Ra’s special,” Glimmer said. “She can heal Saroosh.”

Adora nodded, though she wasn’t as confident as her friend.

“My leaving Saroosh might kill her,” Selmak said.

“I can heal her as soon as you have left her body,” Adora said, drawing her sword.

“I appreciate the attempt.” That wasn’t Selmak - the voice had changed. That was Saroosh! “But I’ve lived a long life. If I don’t survive, don’t blame yourself. Or anyone.”

Adora wouldn’t let the woman die. She nodded anyway.

“Let’s do it,” Saroosh whispered.

Adora wasn’t sure if the woman was talking to her or to Selmak. It didn’t matter. She raised her sword, pointing it at Saroosh and prepared to do her magic. Healing. She had to heal the woman.

Saroosh made a gagging noise and opened her mouth. Adora first thought something had gone wrong - but then she spotted the symbiont’s head appearing on the woman’s tongue, quickly wriggling out of her mouth - and into a container prepared by one of the Tok’ra.

As soon as Selmak was clear, Adora released her magic, and bright, golden light filled the room.

Saroosh froze for a moment, and Adora held her breath. If anything had gone wrong…

But then, the woman sighed, blinking and shivering. "Oh…"

"How do you feel?" Garshaw - no, that was her host, Yosuf, talking. Adora had rarely heard them.

"It's… the pain is gone…" Saroosh blinked again, a smile slowly appearing on her face. A moment later, she started to sit up.

"Wait!" Another Tok'ra said, moving to help her.

But Saroosh waved him away, sitting up in the bed - and then turning, swinging her legs off the bed. "It's… it's incredible." She shook her head and stood up, wobbling for a moment, hunched over, before straightening. "I can move… I feel like I'm young again!"

"Well, you aren't young again," Entrapta said, looking up from her scanner. "Your cells weren't rejuvenated, and your neuroplasticity is at a normal level for an adult. But all the accumulated microdamage in your body was healed."

"That sounds like a rejuvenation effect," Anise pointed out.

"Well, technically, it's not," Entrapta told her. "It's more that this is how her body would be if she had led a perfectly healthy life."

Saroosh seemed to ignore them and moved in front of the aide holding Selmak's container, smiling at the symbiont inside. "It worked."

Adora couldn't see any way that the symbiont could talk or communicate with the woman - except, maybe, the way it swam around - but Saroosh nodded. "Yes, let's rejoin."

The aide handed the container over, and Sarsoosh opened it, then held it below her mouth.

And the symbiont - Selmak - jumped into her mouth. It looked like Saroosh ate them. Well, swallowed them whole.

Once more, Saroosh shivered. And then her eyes lit up, and Selmak spoke. “This is… incredible.”

“If we could have all our elders healed like this…” Per’sus shook his head with a wide smile.

“If this works on symbionts as well…” Malinor turned to face Adora and the others. “You haven’t tested it on symbionts outside a host, have you?”

Adora shook her head. “We didn’t want to risk harming them.” You couldn’t experiment on prisoners. That would be horrible!

“Well, I volunteer!” Malinor said. “We need to know if it works on all of us.”

“Ah…” Adora blinked. That was… a little rash.

“Are you sure?” Glimmer asked. “This could be dangerous. We don’t think that you, as a sapient being, would be harmed by the magic, at least as long as you’re not inside a host, but we have never tested it.”

“Yes, I am sure.” Malinor nodded emphatically. “The knowledge is well worth the risk. If magic can heal symbionts like you healed Saroosh, then this would change everything.”

Adora frowned. They would live a little longer, yes, but how would it change anything?

“Of course, if it works, the next question would be whether it can counteract the negative effects of a sarcophagus,” Anise said. “They aren’t biological in nature.”

“I can’t heal, ah, psychological conditions,” Adora told her. If she could, things would have been a lot easier. A lot of people wouldn’t have had to suffer so much. But that wasn’t her fault.

“Ah. Still, we need to know if you can heal a symbiont.” Malinor nodded again. Firmly.

“Alright.” Adora lifted her sword again as Malinor left her host and slid into the container that had held Selmak before.

Once more, she focused on healing. Just healing. This time, she held her breath as the magical energy hit the container - and the symbiont inside. If she had just killed Malinor…

But the symbiont was moving - and her host, Kalet, grabbed the container so fast, Adora almost expected her to spill the liquid inside. Then Malinor entered Kalet again.

A second passed. Then another, before Kalet took a deep breath - and spoke with Malinor’s voice. “Ah… I was healed. As far as I can tell, at least. And it subtly changed my body - I had to reconnect to Kalet as if I were bonding with her the first time.”

“Oh! Interesting. So, healing has an effect on your neural connections? It didn’t affect Selmak, did it?” Entrapta beamed at her.

“No, it did not. Or, rather, Saroosh was not significantly changed by the experience, so I could easily reconnect,” Selmak replied.

“But symbionts are affected.” Sam looked pensive.

“Yes, that’s certainly a very interesting point that probably should be examined in detail - at some point. But we’re kinda up past our bedtime, and we should return to Earth now before we get grounded by the parents,” Jack cut in, clapping his hand.

“Yes,” Catra agreed. “Unless you have another emergency, we should continue this later.”

"Indeed." Glimmer nodded. "We can schedule a diplomatic meeting at your convenience, where we can discuss this and other topics at leisure."

Garshaw nodded, but Anise and Malinor looked like they disagreed. Well, they looked like Entrapta, who pouted. "But we shouldn't take too long!" Adora's friend said. "This is such an interesting subject to explore!"

And it would be a major part of the negotiations, or so it seemed.

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Saroosh had been healed as expected. Samantha Carter made a note that being a host, even for a long time, did not affect the healing. But it had affected Selmak differently, which was a surprise.

"As we've expected!" Entrapta said, dictating into her recorder. "The subject - I mean, Saroosh - was healed like any other human target of She-Ra's magic. All the microdamage is gone, though the neural structure wasn't altered in any way - though it did have such an effect on Malinor - apparently, a symbiont's body and or neural structure can be altered by the magic." She switched her recorder off. "This is so exciting - a whole new field to study. Glimmer! Do you have records of healing magic from Mystacore? I need a comparison of the healing effects on different species to check if this is specific to symbionts or if it happens to other species as well."

"I don't have such records on me," Glimmer replied. "We can look in our archives once we're back."

Sam didn't know if Glimmer meant back on Earth or back on Etheria and made a mental note to ask about Mystacore once they had some privacy.

"Alright!" Entrapta switched her recorder on again, Sam saw. "Also, there was no transformation of the symbiont into another

species, as observed with Swift Wind, though that may be a result of She-Ra controlling her magic. Further research is necessary."

"A transformation into another species?" Anise asked. "Magic allows a transformation on that level? But you'd have to alter the genetic makeup… just how drastic are the possible changes?"

"There was a chance to alter Malinor's species?" Per'sus asked.

"No," Adora told him. "That was a fluke - I had just gained my powers and wasn't in full control of them. It hasn't happened since then. Not when healing."

"Oh, the changes didn't go further than First Ones experimentation," Entrapta said. "Swift Wind just got functional wings, a horn and sapience - and magic powers."

"Sapience?" Anise stared at them. "You changed a non-sapient species into a sapient one?"

"I didn't mean to!" Adora defended herself.

"You did it by accident?" Even Garshaw was now staring at Adora.

"You achieved what the Ancients did?" Malinor added.

"Well, Adora is a First One," Entrapta said, "Although they generally used magitech, that wouldn't preclude them from doing it with magic."

"Wait!" Anise said, blinking. "You mentioned the First Ones - they were descendants of the Gate Builders. You're an Ancient!"

Sam winced. They hadn't told the Tok'ra that, *technically*, Adora was an Ancient, had they?

"It's not like that! I never knew them!" Adora protested.

But the Tok'ra didn't seem to be listening to her.

“That’s why you have such advanced technology - and magic!” Anise said.

“No!”

“It’s well-known that the most powerful and dangerous technology of the Ancients - and their bases - are genetically locked to their own species,” Molinar went on. “Genetic engineering hasn’t been able to fully bypass that - the System Lords have tried, but there has to be some factor that they are missing.”

What? You couldn’t use genetic engineering techniques to ensure that the Ancient Technology Activation gene was passed on? Of course, the Goa’uld might have simply made a mistake… no. Not for something important. And not for a thousand years. If you couldn’t reliably ensure that your descendants had the gene - no, the gene had to be passed on, or it would have died out amongst humans. But what if it needed an activation trigger…? She glanced at the Colonel.

“Don’t I feel special now,” he muttered.

But did he understand just how special he might be? Of course, the trigger could be something simple - like passing through a gate. You could never tell with the Ancients.

“Well, yes, we can activate their technology,” Adora said. “But I don’t have some genetic memory that tells me how it works. Except for the language…”

“But the First Ones didn’t leave manuals for their technology,” Entrapta said. “Which goes against basic principles of science!” she added with a pout.

“How sloppy of them,” the Colonel commented in a sarcastic tone.

“Exactly!” Entrapta nodded with a smile. “Just think of how much more advanced we would be if they had left proper documentation!”

“And how much more advanced the Goa’ld would be,” Catra commented.

“Oh. Right, that would probably be a bad thing,” Entrapta agreed.

“It would be a catastrophe!” Garshaw said. She seemed to have recovered from the surprise, but she was still focusing on Adora. “So, the Ancients survived. Or rather, they haven’t all gone.”

“Horde Prime claimed he had wiped the First Ones out,” Glimmer said. “Adora might be the last of her people.”

“And the First ones were an offshoot of the Ancients, as far as we know,” Bow added.

Adora nodded. “Yes! I’m not an Ancient - I grew up in the Horde. I can’t just… do what they did.” She turned her head to look at the Colonel. Sam opened her mouth to step in, but Adora was already talking. “In fact, I’m not really any more an Ancient than Jack, who has the Ancient gene. At least Alpha told us that. We’re descendants of colonists.”

Sam suppressed a wince as the Tok’ra turned to look at the Colonel with various but strangely unsettling expressions. Especially Anise’s.

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“So, you are a descendant of the Ancients as well, Colonel O’Neill.”

“So I’ve been told. Although I’m still waiting for a second opinion.”

“I can check your genes, Colonel.”

Catra suppressed the urge to roll her eyes. Anise was staring at O’Neill as if he was… well, if Anise were staring at Adora like that, Catra would consider marking her claim - or clawing the woman.

“I like my genes where they are.”

And speaking of claims… She glanced at Sam. But the woman didn't seem to be ready to do anything violent. Or anything at all. Although she didn't look happy. Not at all. Hell, what did it take for Sam to admit her feelings? Granted, Catra didn't have a lot of room to talk, but Sam hadn't been raised in the Horde by Shadow Weaver but in a normal family.

Well, unless Sam started building killer bots or something to attack rivals or tried to blow up the world, it wasn't any business of Catra's. She had her hands full with Adora, anyway.

Leaning closer to her love, she whispered: "Next time, limit the secrets you blurt out to yours."

Adora grimaced. "I'm so sorry - I panicked!" she whispered back.

"You don't have to apologise to me." But Catra saw that Glimmer didn't look happy either. "I guess we need to talk about OpSec again." And with Entrapta, of course.

"I'm sorry. I'm not used to keeping secrets from everyone."

And wasn't that the truth? Adora wouldn't have made it far as Force Captain - she was just too honest. Not without Shadow Weaver's protection. Then again, Shadow Weaver wanted a loyal, honest minion…

"Anyway, I think we've discussed everything relevant for now," Glimmer said with a fake smile.

Anise opened her mouth to protest, but Garshaw nodded. "Yes. We will start focused negotiations about forming an Alliance soon. And we will extract the Goa'uld from your officer as soon as possible."

"Thank you."

And they would conduct the negotiations with diplomats. And without Adora, if Catra had anything to say about it.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 4th, 1998

"I'm so sorry! They were looking at me like I was a goddess or something, and I, uh, panicked and blurted out your secret!"

Catra sighed. Adora hadn't even been able to wait until they were off the ramp in the gate room. Sure, it had been a gaffe, but it wasn't the end of the world - Catra and the others were very familiar with the difference.

"Well, it probably would have come out anyway at some point, what with all the magic scanners around. Or when we walk into the next Ancient base." O'Neill shrugged, but it looked a little forced to Catra.

Adora, though, seemed to be relieved. "I'm still sorry - I should have been more careful. It wasn't my secret to share."

Glimmer nodded in agreement. "But what's done is done. And we can probably use that in the negotiations."

"What happened?" Ah, the generals had arrived, Sidorov in the lead.

"Well, we didn't start a war," O'Neill told him with a wide grin. "We got a new snake prisoner to go, the Tok'ra have agreed to remove the snake from Lieutenant Lenkova, and we will start negotiations for an Alliance as soon as possible. But I have to insist that there won't be any marriage as part of the Alliance."

"What?" The Russian stared at him in apparent confusion.

Hammond, though, looked like he wanted to sigh. Loudly. "I believe we need a more detailed report, Colonel."

"I made a mistake and revealed that we're descendants from the Ancients," Adora said.

“And that got the Tok’ra very interested in Adora and Colonel O’Neill,” Glimmer said.

“Of course it did.” Entrapa looked confused as well. “Why wouldn’t it? They can access gene-locked First Ones technology - although we don’t know if that extends to all Ancients technology. But the potential is obvious and so helpful with research! Once we find another base, at least - the artefacts we have don’t require them to be studied so far.”

“Yes,” Sam explained. “But we don’t want everyone to know about Adora and Colonel O’Neill.”

“Well, only our friends and allies, right? Honesty is the best policy.” Entrapta nodded.

“The Tok’ra are potential allies. We hope they will join the Alliance, but they haven’t yet,” Glimmer said. “And even then, some secrets are not meant to be shared with everyone.”

“Yeah. Some are private. Or embarrassing.” O’Neill grinned. “I feel old enough even without all the Ancient ancestry jokes.”

“Oh. I shouldn’t have mentioned Adora’s species, then?”

“You revealed classified information?” Sidorov glared at Adora and Entrapta.

Catra narrowed her eyes at him in return. “None that would concern you. Alliance business. Not Stargate Command business.”

“If it concerns Colonel O’Neill, it’s our business!” he protested.

Well, he wasn’t completely wrong. But she wouldn’t let Sidorov attack her friends.

“This was an Alliance mission, General Sidorov. And the Alliance will discuss how to proceed with the Tok’ra.” Glimmer curtly nodded at him. “We’ll retire for the evening - it’s been a long day.” Without waiting for a response, she started towards the door,

leaving the Russian fuming and everyone else from the humans trying to hide their smiles. At least, that was Catra's impression.

Grinning, she tugged on Adora's arm and followed their friends. Sometimes, Glimmer going all "queen" was annoying.

But sometimes, it was great.

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Diplomatic Meetings Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 4th, 1998

"...and then we returned through the gate." Jack O'Neill resisted the urge to add 'The End!' even if it took some effort. But while it would annoy Sidorov, it would also annoy Hammond, and the general didn't deserve that - he had to deal with Sidorov much more than Jack had to.

The Russian prick hadn't stopped scowling since they had returned. He was almost the total opposite of Dr Iwan the Too-Helpful - where the scientist was all smiles, all the time, the general was seeing enemies everywhere. Of course, with his personality, he was bound to make enemies everywhere…

"Thank you, Colonel." Haig nodded. The Limey was always polite and professional. Too polite for Jack's taste. But better that than Sidorov's paranoia.

"So, you suspect that the Tok'ra do not have a queen and can't grow their numbers?" Petit asked, frowning a little.

"It's a possibility," Jack replied. "We have no way to verify it."

"But if it is true, that will influence the upcoming negotiations." Petit nodded. "Of course, that's beyond our own remit as Stargate Command."

Sidorov scowled even more at that. "We are involved as well - the diplomatic contact was only possible because of the Stargate. Any deal with aliens affects our own security - and the security of Earth itself."

"I concur," General Li said. "While every country is, of course, free to make alliances as they see fit, the Stargate is under the control of the United Nations. It is our duty as Stargate Command to ensure that everyone who uses it does so in a responsible manner

and doesn't put our world at risk. This necessitates a certain involvement. We cannot do our duty to guard both the Stargate and the world otherwise."

That sounded rehearsed, at least to Jack. Though Li usually talked more formally. But what were Russia and China planning? Did they really want to seek allies of their own in the galaxy? Or was this just an attempt to force their way into the Alliance by threatening to form an alliance with other aliens if they didn't get their way? Or were they serious about trying to control the Stargate? But the Alliance included three of the five permanent members of the UN Security Council. Russia and China were outnumbered there. They could use their veto powers creatively, of course, or raise some trouble with the rest of the United Nations - the majority of the countries on Earth were not members of the Alliance, after all, and a lot of them had no real chances to join in the near future for a variety of reasons.

"I believe that SG-1 and our Etherian friends took every precaution when reaching out to an alien power at war with the Goa'uld," Haig said. "I also would like to point out that this contact occurred as a result of one of our exploration missions going missing."

"Which is another reason why this involves Stargate Command," Sidorov snapped. "Stargate Teams were involved from the start."

"To recover our missing team," Petit retorted. "Which was accomplished before the mission to contact the Tok'ra was even contemplated, I believe."

"Nevertheless, as my colleague has said before, SG-1 was an essential part of the contact mission." Li smiled. "And SG-1 is part of Stargate Command. They have performed diplomatic duties before as well if I recall correctly."

"First contacts," Hammond told him. "But this isn't about first contact any more - this is now a matter between the Alliance and the Tok'ra, not Stargate Command."

"It is a matter that concerns the entire world," Li objected.

"You got the entire planet into a war with aliens before without telling anyone else on Earth!" Sidorov snapped. "The United Nations took control of the Stargate to prevent a repeat of that. And now you want to form an alliance with Goa'uld!"

"Uh, the Tok'ra do not consider themselves Goa'uld - in fact, they consider it an insult to be called Goa'uld," Daniel pointed out. "That was in our report."

While Jack's friend weathered the glare from the Russian, Jack studied Li. The Chinese general was hard to read, but he had to have a plan - he had to be aware that Haig, Hammond and Petit could and would block him from trying to mess with the upcoming diplomatic negotiations. And even if they didn't, Glimmer wouldn't let Li stop her.

"Whatever!" Sidorov spat. "But they are the same species - they can take control of your body! And we cannot be sure that they aren't infiltrated by our enemies! This contact represents a significant risk for our world!"

"We've taken every precaution to minimise the risks," Haig said.

"And yet, seeing as your country is a part of the Alliance with the Etherians, some might question how objective you can be," Li retorted with a polite smile. "I think this question is a political one, not a military one, and has to be settled on an international level."

Were they planning to use the United Nations to delay further missions to contact the Tok'ra until their demands - whatever they were - were met? Jack couldn't tell but he wouldn't put it past the Russians and Chinese to try to hold the world hostage.

Well, he added with a grin, let's see how that works out for them. Not only were the most powerful NATO countries united in this, but he had a feeling that Glimmer wouldn't be amused either.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 4th, 1998

"Do you think Jack is mad at me?" Adora asked after their shuttle had touched down inside Darla's hangar.

"Dunno," Catra replied with a shrug. "He'll get over it," she added as she hit the button to open the door with her fist.

Adora frowned. "I'm really sorry."

"And you told him that. More than once," Catra stretched her hands over her head as she walked down the ramp. "Home sweet home."

Adora sighed. Catra might not be the best person to ask about this. She was incredibly biased in favour of Adora. In fact, Catra would take her side over Jack's no matter what happened, Adora was sure of that. And, of course, Catra's view of what was a serious mistake was slightly skewed because of her past.

She bit her lower lip. And by asking her lover, she was poking at the scars left from that part of their life. Oh, she was just making more mistakes, was she?

An elbow in her ribs started her. "Hey!" she blurted out.

Catra grinned at her. "You were putting yourself down again for no reason. Sure, you made a mistake, but it wasn't a big one. Sooner or later, it would have come out anyway, as Jack said." She narrowed her eyes at Adora with the last bit.

"I know…" Adora sighed. Sure, Jack had said that. But had he meant it? She was well aware of the influence they had on Earth. And while Jack wasn't a politician - he complained about them often enough - he would know that. She didn't think he would actually lie to her because of it, but… How would she know?

"Yes, you know," Glimmer said, joining them with Bow, who had finished shutting down the shuttle's systems. "So stop beating

yourself up over it. Besides, Entrapta blurted out your secret, and you're not mad at her, are you?"

"Of course not!" Adora suppressed the urge to check if Entrapta had heard them - they had dropped off their friend in her spacelab before continuing to Darla.

"And we're supposed to be honest with our friends - and future friends," Bow added with a smile. "If they found out later that we've kept such a secret from them, it would be worse."

"And Jack should know that," Catra said.

"I know." But Entrapta blurting out something in her excitement was different than Adora revealing Jack's secret to protect herself.

"Oh, come on!" Catra sighed. "No one's perfect. Not even you."

"I know." Adora couldn't help pouting.

"Now come! I want to grab a snack before we go to bed. It's been a long day." Catra tugged on her arm.

"You've eaten half the buffet at the dinner!" Glimmer pointed out.

"Only the fish dishes!" Catra defended herself.

"Those were half the buffet!" Glimmer snorted.

"No, the fried fish was actually fried brain."

"What? You're joking!" Glimmer gasped.

"No, it's the truth!" Catra grinned widely.

"And you didn't tell us?"

"Well, I thought you could use some more brains." Catra released Adora's arm and dashed towards the kitchen.

"Oh, you!"

Adora giggled while Glimmer shook her head. She felt a little better as well - her friends were right, after all.

But there was something niggling at her still.

*****

A while and a tuna sandwich later - Adora reminded herself to make sure that they took enough canned tuna for Catra back to Etheria when they returned - Adora was on the bed in their cabin, and Catra was changing into her sleeping clothes. Which was stripping down to her underwear, mostly.

And that was a very distracting sight, even when Catra wasn't trying to tease Adora like she was doing right now. And it was working. Especially when she kept stripping past the underwear before crawling onto the bed, and…

But afterwards, even with Catra resting her head on Adora's chest, the niggling was back. Adora stared at the ceiling above their bed - weirdly as it was, the metal ceiling felt more familiar than the decorated ceiling back in Bright Moon - and sighed.

"You know, after what we just did, you should sigh with a lot more satisfaction," Catra complained at once.

"Sorry." Adora sighed again. "I just can't stop thinking about something. I mean, it keeps coming back." She had stopped thinking about anything or anyone but Catra for quite a while just before, after all.

Catra snorted. "This better be a subtle way to ask me for another round without asking."

Adora had to chuckle at that despite her mood. "I would just ask," she told her lover.

Or kiss her and see where it would lead to.

“I don’t know. Sometimes, you try to do something because you saw it on TV.” Catra smirked at her

Adora pouted for a moment. The rose petal thing had seemed a good idea at the time. Who would have known that Darla would send the cleaning bots in?

Catra shifted, sliding on top of her and facing Adora. “So, what’s got you more distracted than me?”

“It’s not that!” Adora protested. Catra was much more important than that!

In response, Catra raised her eyebrows.

Once more, Adora sighed. “It’s about today’s mistake - but not in the way you think it is,” she quickly added when her lover started to frown. “I was just asking myself if I could trust Jack is telling the truth when he said his secret would have come out anyway and so it’s OK. You know, in a general way.”

Catra blinked. “How do you mean? He is sneaky, yes, but he also is honest with his friends. Mostly.”

Mostly? Adora filed that away for another discussion, “No, I meant in general. We’ve got a lot of power. On Earth, and back home.”

Catra nodded, but in her ‘get on with it, you dummy’ way.

“So, how much can we trust people to be honest with us? How likely is it that someone’s going to lie to us because they fear we wouldn’t like the truth and take it out on them?” Adora bit her lower lip.

Catra blinked again, and Adora felt her grow tense for a moment before she took a deep breath and shifted a little on Adora. “Ah. Like in the Horde?”

“Yes, exactly!” Adora nodded. The instructors, Shadow Weaver, Hordak - basically, everyone - had demanded that they were

honest, but if you told the truth, be it your opinion or just a fact, and they didn't like it, odds were you got punished for it.

Catra tilted her head, her shoulders twitching a little, the best she could to shrug in her position. "We're not the Horde. People know we won't punish them for being honest. Well, we'll punish them if they deserve it for other reasons."

"But what if they don't know that?" Adora bit her lower lip. "They don't know us that well - they haven't grown up with us. They haven't fought with us." Catra opened her mouth, and Adora quickly added: "I don't mean Jack, Sam, Daniel and Teal'c. I mean the rest of Earth."

"Ah." Another twitch-shrug followed. "They'll learn. We are being honest about it, after all. Even I." Catra grinned.

"But until then?" Adora took a deep breath. "And what about back home? How many people know us there? I mean, really know us?"

Catra snorted, but her smile twisted a little. "Enough know me, at least."

That again. "You've changed," Adora told her - as firmly as she could.

"Even so, many won't know that," Catra told her. "Former Horde soldiers still give me weird looks when they see me."

Adora frowned. "'Weird'? Like, they can't believe you're in the Alliance?" With her? "Or they don't trust you?" Lonnie had taken a while, Adora knew, to trust Catra. At least Adora assumed Lonnie had started to trust Catra since it had been a while since the last time that their friend had asked Adora what she thought about Catra's change of allegiance. Maybe she should ask Lonnie about that…

"That too," Catra said, shrugging again. "But they also look at me like they did back in the Horde. When they think I can't see them,

at least. You know, hoping I won't notice any mistake or something and will leave soon."

Oh. That was… well, it made sense. That was how things were - had been - in the Horde. Catra had been in charge of the Horde for a few years, after all. And if you displeased your superior, there wasn't much they couldn't do to you. Every cadet had that beaten into them, Literally sometimes.

"But you know, that's the Horde. Former Horde," Catra said.

Adora knew that. But… "And what if people in Bright Moon think the same and are just better at hiding it?"

"They aren't better at hiding it," Catra said with a twisted smile. "Trust me."

Adora narrowed her eyes. They were giving her a hard time? If she found out who… She blinked again. "Oh."

"It's nothing," Catra said. "I did try to destroy them a few times, after all." She didn't sound entirely honest, though - Adora knew her too well to fall for her tone.

"It's not nothing," Adora told her. "But I just caught myself thinking that I had to straighten out whoever was doing… whatever. And that would be…" She pressed her lips together.

"Oh," Catra echoed her. "Yeah, that would make them hide their real feelings. More than they do, at least."

"You think they're already doing that?"

"Everyone's doing that," Catra said with a snort. "Somewhat, at least. You don't take out your bad mood on people. And you don't complain to just anyone if you feel down."

"You know what I mean," Adora retorted.

"Well, do you go up to people and tell them: 'I think you're with the wrong person and should pick someone else'?" Catra raised her eyebrows.

What? Adora clenched her jaws as she felt another, stronger urge to have a talk with whoever was… Oh, she was doing it again. But this was different. "Well, if they were a friend and I were really concerned…" But she didn't know anyone like that.

Catra snorted once more. "So, that's normal. It wasn't a Horde thing. Or not just a Horde thing."

"But it was worse there," Adora retorted. "And it's one thing to not mention something about someone's private life, but what if it's about the war?" Lying about the war could lead to disaster. You needed to trust your troops and the information they told you.

"I don't think either the Princess Alliance or the Earth countries in the alliance are like that," Catra said. "We've been working with the Americans long enough to tell."

"Yes." Adora slowly, if a little awkwardly, nodded - she was still on her back, after all.

But she still couldn't help worrying that things weren't as well as they should be.

Because Catra, Hordak and Scorpia had changed for the better - well, Scorpia didn't really have to change, just realise a few things - but what if a princess changed for the worse? Not Adora's friends, of course; they might carry grudges, but they were good people. But there were a lot of princesses on Etheria. And not all of them would be as brave and good as Adora's friends.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 5th, 1998

“Normally, I’d hate to work on a Saturday, but I’ll make an exception to watch another Goa’uld get sucked out of their host.”

Samantha Carter suppressed a chuckle at the Colonel’s comment - it would only encourage him, and she wasn’t sure how General Sidorov would react to more humour. The man seemed determined to prove the Cold War stereotype of humourless Russians true. Fortunately, the general was hovering near the stretcher onto which they had strapped Lieutenant Lenkova and so was out of earshot.

A fact the Colonel seemed determined to exploit. “Well, looks like even our Russian paranoid officer in charge isn’t too far gone. Unless, of course, he hovers over the Lieutenant because he expects her to break the straps and go for a gun, and he wants first dibs at shooting her.”

Sam knew better than to comment. Daniel, of course, didn’t. “Why would he want to shoot his own officer, Jack?”

And, as expected, the Colonel jumped on it. “For failing, of course, Daniel! A true Russian soldier wouldn’t have let themselves get possessed, don’t you know? And failure is treason!”

“But…” Daniel’s also inevitable retort was cut off when the gate crew started the activation sequence.

Sam raised her head as she watched the chevrons getting locked, followed by the vortex billowing out, then collapsing into the stable wormhole. Even after countless trips, it was still an awe-inspiring sight for anyone who realised just how advanced the technology behind this was.

“Our request was answered. Codes match the ones we exchanged with the Tok’ra,” Siler announced.

“Alright, kids! Time to get another snake prisoner!” The Colonel turned to the Russian team guarding Lenkova. “We’ll go first, and you follow. And don’t stumble while going through the gate - we don’t want you to get lost on the way!”

The Russians didn't react to the weak joke and only moved at a nod from Sidorov. Sam sighed, hefted the transport box - she wasn't going to call it a snake carrier despite the Colonel's suggestion - and walked up the ramp. Once more into the breach. At least it felt like it.

And then she went from the slightly stale and ionised air of the gate room into the hot, dry air of a desert planet. A group of Tok'ra were waiting for them on the other side of the gate, as expected. Martouf/Lantash was amongst them, which Sam had expected as well. And dreaded to some degree - she wasn't ready to deal with… their expectations. She wasn't Jolinar reborn. She had some of Jolinar's memories, but that was it. And she most certainly wasn't ready to enter a relationship with anyone, least of all a host/symbiont union! Would that be a ménage-à-trois? Technically, she supposed. Not that they would have actually said anything concrete, but the undertone… She pushed the thought away as they walked down the ramp. They were here for Lieutenant Lenkova, nothing else.

Behind them, the Russian team - formerly their second team, now their first, with Lenkova's team all but wiped out - followed through the Stargate, two carrying Lenkova on her stretcher and the other two with their weapons out.

They looked nervous and were trying not to show it. Well, Sam had to trust that they wouldn't start shooting their allies. Perhaps a subtle warning to the Tok'ra would not go amiss…

But their hosts were already bringing up their transport.

"So, are we going back to the decoy base, or did you grow a special base for this?" the Colonel asked with a wide smile. "Hey, is it actually easier for you to grow a new base than clean your old one?"

To Sam's relief, the Tok'ra didn't take offence. Martouf - no, that was Lantash - even laughed. "No, Colonel, it's not quite that easy. And we wouldn't want to leave too many bases, lest we make the

Goa'uld wonder how we are building them if they stumble on a complex we left. Of course, now that they are aware of our capability, we might reconsider your suggestion - no one likes to be on janitorial duty, after all!"

The Colonel laughed in return. "Oh, yes!" In a lower voice, he added: "Who would have thought that aliens have a better sense of humour than our own allies?"

"Well, Jack, since you always complain about Russians - and Germans - having no sense of humour, obviously, you should have expected that we would encounter aliens with a better sense of humour sooner or later," Daniel said as they climbed into the transport. "Although, of course, just as what is considered funny varies considerably on Earth, the same would be true for alien civilisations…"

"It was a rhetorical question, Daniel."

"Oh."

Sam was sure the Colonel knew that Daniel was aware of that and was just using the opportunity to annoy the Colonel back a little. But it was all part of their team dynamic.

"How have you been?" Martouf asked, sitting down near her as the transport took off.

Sam forced herself to smile. Politely. "Busy writing reports and dealing with other paperwork. Assessing experiments." Instead of, say, working on the spacelab with Entrapta. "What about you?"

"Ah, we were also busy dealing with the aftermath of the infiltration." He smiled in that familiar manner - familiar to Jolinar, Sam reminded herself. "Entrapta isn't coming?"

"No. She is busy in her lab," Sam told him. And, as she had confided in Sam, she didn't want to risk revealing more information to the Tok'ra that might get her friends angry or in trouble until they were officially part of the Alliance.

“Ah. Anise and Molinar will be disappointed.” Martouf grinned. “They will attempt to monopolise you, I fear.”

“I hope it won’t be too bad.” Sam would actually prefer dealing with Anise and Molinar to chatting awkwardly with her former symbiont’s ex-lovers.

Very much so, she added to herself when she saw Martouf smile again.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 5th, 1998

“...and if we were to provide them with hosts, we would create a huge security risk - the Tok’ra would be aware of everything their hosts know. Everything,” the German representative, their Verteidigungsminister, repeated himself.

The German general next to him nodded in agreement. He had been doing that a lot, Catra had noticed. She couldn’t tell if he was just going along with his superior’s opinion or if he fully shared the view. Not that it mattered - the Germans were very clear about how their military was under the complete control of their government, as if that was not how things should be anyway. Glimmer would fire any officer in Bright Moon’s military who disobeyed her orders, and many princesses would do the same - or worse.

“So what?” The French Ministre de la Défense shrugged. “Don’t let them possess any member of the military, past or present, and I don’t see the problem.”

“Even civilians know a lot about our military and politics!” the German retorted. “A significant part of the population has military experience!”

“Experience that is now outdated in key points,” the British Secretary of State for Defense cut in. “Yes, they will be familiar

with our combat doctrine and weapons, which we will be using in the upcoming campaign, but the enemy is already aware of at least our small unit tactics thanks to their little war with the United States. And once we start a serious ground campaign, they will also be aware of our armoured forces and air forces."

That ruffled the Americans' feathers, Catra could tell. "We have dealt decisive blows to the enemy," their Secretary of Defense snapped. "But we do share our German allies' concerns about crucial intelligence being fed to the Tok'ra. As we all have agreed, this war won't be a strictly military affair but will also rely on a civil campaign to educate the indoctrinated population of the enemy and especially their forces. Even information about Earth's culture is significant in this context."

"We are talking about the Tok'ra, not the Goa'uld. If we agree to let them recruit hosts, then that will be part of the Alliance agreement. Which means they will be our allies," Adora pointed out.

"That doesn't mean we can trust them with such information," the German minister insisted. "Even amongst allies, you do not share everything."

"Although sometimes, that includes things you should have shared." The British minister wasn't looking at the American one, but it was clear what he was talking about.

And this time, the American gritted his teeth and didn't respond.

They were still carrying grudges over Stargate Command being kept a secret. Catra sighed softly. She could understand the sentiment, but it wasn't really helpful.

"Are you saying that you expect the Tok'ra to… undermine our efforts to liberate and educate the Goa'uld slaves?" Adora frowned at them. "Have you read our report about how much care they show in recruiting hosts?"

"We're aware of their claims, yes," the German minister replied. "But we have to consider the long-term issues. Nations do not have friends; they have interests, as our British allies are fond of saying. And while currently, everyone's interests align with regard to the war against the Goa'uld Empire, that might not be the case any more once the enemy is defeated."

Adora scowled at that. Catra did so as well. That sounded as if they expected another conflict to break out after they had beaten the Goa'uld - just like it had on Earth after their last world war. Not a really unrealistic view, in Catra's opinion, given what she knew about Earth. On the other hand, she knew that one of the surest ways to start a conflict - or a war - was to assume it would happen anyway.

"But even if we disregard that slightly pessimistic view," the French minister said, "there remains the question of loyalty. Any host would become a Tok'ra, according to what we know about their society - a life-long partner of their 'symbiont'. How is that supposed to be a true partnership?"

"Just as marriage is supposed to be a true partnership?" Catra asked, cocking her head. That was the obvious answer, in her opinion.

"There are parallels to marriages between citizens of different nations, though as our history taught us, couples formed by people from different countries are often put under heavy strain if their countries are in conflict," the British minister said.

"And it's a bit more… encompassing… than mere marriage," the American general pointed out with a smile. "I'm not sharing the same body with my wife."

"The issue is, can we trust our citizens to remain loyal when entering such a relationship? Ultimately, the Tok'ra can enforce their will on them if push comes to shove," the American minister said. "This needs to be a concern when selecting hosts."

Adora frowned again. “The Tok’ra would be selecting the hosts from volunteers.”

“Yes, but it’s obvious that we need to veto those amongst the volunteers that are unsuitable for security reasons,” the American retorted.

“That depends on whether or not there are many volunteers,” the Minister from Canada added. “I can’t imagine that there would be too many of them who would want to share their body with an alien.”

“There are billions of humans. There will be a lot of them,” the American minister told him. “And what do we do about volunteers from outside the alliance?”

“We need to stipulate in any agreement with the Tok’ra that they limit their recruiting efforts to our own countries,” the German minister replied. “If we successfully negotiate an alliance, of course.”

That seemed to be a tad optimistic. Catra shrugged. “The Tok’ra are already aware that Earth isn’t united. What if they want to open relations with other countries if they feel we’re too restrictive or something?”

“And do we have the right to keep someone from entering such a partnership? That would be like telling people they can’t marry,” Adora added.

“Well, I think it’s not quite like that,” the American minister said.

“Imagine if the Tok’ra get hosts from the Russians… or the Chinese…” The German minister shook his head. “Either would love to send a spy to get all the advanced knowledge of the aliens.”

“Or Iran or North Korea. And if the Tok’ra become influenced by such extremist ideologies…” The American minister looked grim.

"Well, don't try to restrict them too much, then, so they have no need to seek out other hosts?" Catra offered with a shrug.

None of the people present seemed to like that idea. But they didn't seem to like the alternative even less.

"I guess we can't really keep them off Earth. Not unless we are ready to go to war…" the American general muttered.

"We are trying to make allies, not enemies," Adora reminded him. Once again, the others present didn't seem to like it.

Catra hoped that Glimmer was doing better in her meeting with the foreign ministers.

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P34-353J, December 5th, 1998

And there went another snake, Jack O'Neill thought as the laser-syringe-teleporter thingie started to work on Lenkova. The woman was, fortunately, sedated - the procedure hurt like hell as far as they had been told by the Tok'ra.

They also had been told that there was a chance of failure. Failure to stop the Goa'uld from killing the host, to be exact - it wouldn't fail to extract the snake. But Jack wouldn't dwell on that. It had worked with the Tok'ra host taken over by the Goa'uld spy. It would have to work with Lenkova as well. The woman didn't deserve to be killed by a damn snake, and certainly not in that way.

He carefully schooled his features, projecting confidence as he watched the procedure. Lenkova was one of his soldiers. He was, at least partially, responsible for this, anyway. If he had trained her a bit better, maybe she could've avoided capture. If he had let the fact that she was a Russian spy influence his training her... No, he didn't think he had. But he had been avoiding her outside training.

Daniel was watching intently as well. Jack wondered if his friend was seeing Sha're on the table here. Jack was familiar with things like that. And with personal failures.

He pressed his lips together. This wasn't the time to go there. He forced the thoughts of his family - his former family - away and glanced around. The Tok'ra present were mumbling under their breath. Probably doing that recital thing on the sly - Jakar would have told them the name of the Goa'uld inside Lenkova and their crimes. Jakar was present himself, but that was understandable. This was the Goa'uld scumbag who had almost got away when he had blown up the bioweapons research lab. Jack would've attended as well in the Tok'ra's place.

Anise was at the controls of the extractor, with Carter watching her as intently as the others were watching Lenkova. Jack envied his SIC. To be able to focus on something in a situation like this instead of having the time to let your mind wander to places you didn't want to touch must be great. And Jack would bet a week's worth of dessert on Carter already planning to copy the extractor. Or improve on it. Probably with Entrapta's help. They couldn't rely on the Tok'ra for this forever, could they?

He looked at the Russian team. They looked a bit nervous and trying to hide it. That was understandable, in Jack's opinion - this was their first real mission off-world. Their leader, Lieutenant Babanin, wasn't the most creative officer Jack had ever met, to say the least, but he wasn't the worst either. Solid came to mind as a description, though he was a bit too prone to follow orders to the letter. But that was a problem with all Russian soldiers. And the Chinese, too. But he and his men would do. At least for this - Jack wasn't quite sure he'd trust them in every situation. Not with Sidorov in charge. If the damn Russian started meddling and endangering Jack's people…

His thoughts were interrupted by the extractor finishing - the lights changed, and Jack could spot some snake inside the tube. Jakar stepped forward and took it, removing the container from

the extractor. The spy stared at it for a moment before handing it over to Carter.

Yeah, I would have wanted to smash the snake as well, Jack thought. But they needed prisoners, and the Etherians wouldn't take well to such killings. For people coming from a world ruled by absolute monarchs and the closest thing to United Nations or international law being a ball thrown for princesses every ten years and 'whatever they agreed upon at the buffet small-talk', they certainly took human rights seriously. Or alien rights.

"I'm administering the counter-agent to the sedative," Anise announced. She stepped up to Lenkova and injected something into her. "Provided you have given us the correct data and drug, she should be waking up soon."

"We have," Jack told her, nodding curtly. No sense encouraging the snake - she had been staring at him like some recruit in basic seeing a decent home-cooked meal for the first time in weeks before the procedure had started.

"Good. It is a pleasure working with you, Colonel O'Neill." And there she was doing it again, smiling far too warmly at him.

He shrugged. "Ah, just doing what we can."

"And you can do a lot, I am sure." She took a step closer, and Jack fought the urge to take a step back. Or call for help. He could handle a pushy woman, snake or not.

That didn't mean he wasn't grateful for the distraction when Carter spoke up: "Lieutenant Lenkova is waking up."

And she was. He could see her shift, pulling against the straps - which Carter quickly released - before opening her eyes, blinking and mumbling. "Что случилось?" Then her eyes focused on Jack, and she gasped.

He smiled as warmly at her as he could. "You were possessed by a Goa'uld, Lieutenant," he told her. "But our new friends removed

it. You're free."

She kept blinking. "Free… he's gone… Oh."

Then the tears came, and Jack stepped away. Carter could handle this. Lenkova wouldn't want her superior officer to see her cry.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 5th, 1998

"Oh, I'm so glad we got an excuse to skip the next 'planning session' in Brussels!"

Adora smiled at Catra's comment as she stepped off the shuttle ramp at the Stargate Command landing pad. The military had already discussed all of the parts of the Tok'ra Alliance proposal to be put forward that fell under their area of influence. At least as far as Adora could tell - they had been rehashing the same points at the end of the last session. So, it wasn't as if they were doing any harm by skipping the rest of the meetings.

"Welcome to Stargate Command!"

Jack was there, personally greeting them? Adora frowned. He hadn't been doing that for months now.

"What's wrong?" Catra asked before Adora could. "You wouldn't be out here for no reason."

Jack raised his eyebrows. "What? You don't think I would want to personally welcome you to the hallowed halls of Stargate Command?"

Catra narrowed her eyes. "And stand around in this cold?" She pointed at the snow on the ground to the side. "It's so bad, I have to wear shoes!"

"Ah, you get used to it after the first bout of frostbite. And soon, anything above freezing starts feeling hot." Jack grinned for a moment, then grew serious, More or less. "I've actually used the opportunity to check out the work on the 'shuttleport'," he added, pointing to the construction site next to the pad.

"You're expanding?" Adora asked. "I thought you were relocating. Or is this to make it easier to move?"

"Stargate Command is moving. The Mountain's still one of the key command centres of the United States - and the world. With shuttles finally in production in the US - and rolling off the assembly lines in Canada already, somehow - that means we'll need shuttleports to be ready for them. At least, that's what the Pentagon says."

"You could use airports and Air Force bases," Catra pointed out. "Shuttles don't need more space than a landing pad."

"Yep, that would be the logical course of action." Jack snorted. "But unlike constructing entirely new ports, using existing infrastructure wouldn't net the construction firms as much money. And the brass claims we need the experience." He shrugged. "Some people are already predicting that airports will be replaced by shuttleports, causing mass layoffs and all that stuff. Stupid, of course, as long as most countries of the world don't have shuttles and are stuck with airplanes, but I expect some protesters forming outside our base any day now. Well, maybe once it's a bit warmer…"

Catra shrugged. "Shuttles are more convenient. And safer."

"But we don't have enough of them, and won't have for a long while, to replace civilian air traffic. Not to mention we don't have civilian shuttle models at all." Jack grinned. "And trust me, civilians won't want to fly military. Hell, I don't want to fly military if I can get a nice American Airlines flight instead. The service is much better, and the stewardesses are prettier."

Adora chuckled at his weak joke.

“You want to flirt with stewardesses?” Catra shook her head. “You like to court danger, do you?”

Jack narrowed his eyes for a moment before grinning - a bit toothily. “As an Air Force officer, it’s my duty to flirt with stewardesses. It’s in the regs.”

“Should I ask Sam what she thinks of those regulations?”

“Female officers are exempt,” Jack retorted in a flat voice. “Anyway,” he continued a little more loudly, “let’s get inside before we freeze our butts off here.” He clapped his hands together for emphasis.

“Yes,” Adora agreed. “How’s Lieutenant Lenkova?” she asked as they walked towards the entrance.

That caused Jack to wince and grow serious. “She’s doing as well as you can expect when you’ve had a snake in your head. Fortunately, she was unconscious for most of it, so it was just a short time, but…” He shrugged.

“Yes,” Catra agreed in a clipped tone.

Her lover was remembering her time under Horde Prime’s control, Adora knew. She reached out and held Catra’s hand, squeezing gently, and was rewarded with a familiar smile and Catra’s tail rising.

Adora nodded as they stepped through the gate. Catra had recovered. And Lieutenant Lenkova would as well. In any case, Adora would do what she could to help her along, which included healing her. That’s what they were here for, after all. Amongst other things. And to get away from more meetings.

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Diplomatic Meetings Part 2

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 5th, 1998

Samantha Carter took another look at Lieutenant Lenkova. The woman was asleep. Finally. And the nurse had wiped away the tears tracts on her cheeks. And the snot from her nose. Magical healing didn't clean you up, she absent-mindedly noted. At least not when whatever residue was left didn't endanger your health. But Adora's magic certainly had healed all remaining injuries of the officer in the bed. There was no need for infusions or further treatment - not physical, at least.

She stepped out of the room and closed the door behind her. The two Russian guards outside nodded at her without a word. Sam wanted to say something supportive, but she couldn't think of one that wouldn't have felt trite or stupid.

So she nodded back and walked to the lift. She felt guilty for leaving, but there was nothing more that she could do for Lenkova right now, and she couldn't just sit at the woman's bedside - she had her own duties. Duties that required access to her lab.

But first, she had a report to make. So she headed to the Colonel's office.

"...and so I told the guy: 'Use it or lose it'. And he lost it."

The Colonel was behind his desk, telling a story to Adora and Catra that Sam had heard before. Adora was nodding along on the seat in front of the desk, but Catra was sitting on the edge of the desk, on top of several papers, and stretching. Once more, it struck Sam just how much Catra often acted like a cat. The effects of the spliced genes that had gone into her ancestors must be more profound than Sam would have expected. Maybe if she had a scan of the woman's brain…

“So, how is the Lieutenant?” the Colonel interrupted her stray thought. Which she shouldn’t have had - she must be more tired than she thought.

“Asleep,” Sam replied. “Physically, she’s fine, but mentally…” She pressed her lips together.

“She’ll get over it,” Catra said with a nod. It sounded confident but also a little dismissive. “It wasn’t her fault that she was possessed.”

Ah. Of course, given what Sam knew about Catra’s past, it made sense she would think like that. “People aren’t rational like that when it comes to trauma,” Sam pointed out. “And she blames herself for failing her team.” Lenkova had said as much to Sam before falling asleep.

The Colonel winced. He, too, would be familiar with guilt, Sam knew. He would be able to talk to Lenkova about what she was going through, but… Sam wasn’t sure she liked the idea. On the other hand, she didn’t really trust most of the therapists on Stargate Command’s payroll to handle this. They simply lacked experience with what Lenkova had gone through. Sam knew - to some degree - how having your body taken over felt. But she didn’t know how losing your team as a leader felt.

“But it wasn’t her fault!” Adora said, shaking her head. “Sometimes, you do everything right, and you still fail. And it was her first mission against the Goa’uld.”

Catra snorted, though Sam didn’t see what would be amusing about the comment, and the Colonel shook his head. “All members of Stargate Command are highly-trained and skilled soldiers. And most of them have combat experience in some form. She will blame herself for missing something or giving the wrong order.” He scoffed. “Trust me, I know that feeling.”

Catra nodded in agreement. “But she’ll get over it,” she repeated herself.

Sam wanted to ask if the woman was speaking from experience, but that would be… You didn't ask about things like that. Not in this situation, when they were talking about Lenkova. And Sam was certain that Catra wouldn't react well to any attempt to poke into her past. Not at all. The catwoman would probably react like the Colonel. Or more rudely. No, some sleeping dogs - or cats - were better left in peace.

"I hope so. I wish I could heal trauma." Adora sighed.

"You can't just wave your magic wand and solve everything," the Colonel said with a shrug. His tone was a little less gentle than Sam would have expected. He generally wasn't as short with Adora.

Oh. He was feeling guilty as well since Lenkova had been one of his officers.

She suppressed a sigh. This was worse than she had thought. She wished she could just hole up in the spacelab until someone solved this. She wasn't a trained psychologist, anyway.

But she wouldn't desert her team. Nor her commanding officer.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 6th, 1998

"You wanted to see me, General?" Samantha Carter asked after sitting down in General Hammond's office. She kept her tone polite, of course - the general had earned her respect. Even though she really wanted to return to her work; with Lieutenant Lenkova still asleep, Sam wanted to use the time to deal with her paperwork and then advance a research project or two - the lines to the spacelab were working, and she really wanted to test the waldos with Entrapta.

"Yes, I did, Captain." The General nodded. He took a deep breath, clearly uncomfortable - Sam knew him well enough.

And she was suddenly worried. General Hammond usually came straight to the point. And not just because he was usually swamped with work. If he was hesitating, then something was wrong. But was it something that concerned Stargate Command? He had only called her, not the rest of SG-1. That meant it was personal. What could have happened? She pressed her lips together before she blurted the question out. Instead, she kept meeting the general's eyes.

He sighed once more. "It's your father, Captain. Jacob."

Sam frowned a little as she slightly tilted her head. She hadn't had contact with her father since that embarrassing meeting in Washington months ago - before she met the Etherians. What could he have done now? And why was General Hammond concerned about it? Her father was stubborn and prideful to a fault - he still hadn't contacted her, and she certainly wouldn't contact him after it had been revealed just how important her position was, contrary to his assumptions - but she couldn't think of anything he'd actually do that would worry the general. Her father wasn't stupid. "Yes?"

"Now, he didn't tell *me*, but his aide called me, and…"

Sam nodded. She was aware of how information was passed on through such unofficial channels. But what was it that the General was so hesitant to mention?

"So, long story short, Captain, Jacob has cancer. Terminal cancer."

Sam gasped. Her father was dying? From cancer? Why didn't he tell me?

General Hammond winced, and she realised she had asked that question out loud. "Well, he probably didn't want to appear trying to use your friendship with the Etherians to get preferential treatment."

But… "He's a major general! Surely the United States would ask the Etherians to heal him. He's…" Important and influential

enough to have offered Sam help to get into the NASA astronaut program. Not that she would have accepted the help - if she had achieved it through nepotism, it would have been worthless. And she was already involved with Stargate Command, anyway.

Once more, General Hammond winced. "Not against his will, I suppose. And…" He shook his head. "Jacob is a proud man. He might be hoping that advanced technology will be adapted in time to heal him."

That sounded like her father. Too proud to ask his daughter for help after she refused his help. But that would still mean that her father didn't tell his superiors that his cancer was terminal - something she wouldn't put past him.

Ultimately, it didn't matter - nothing would change the fact that she couldn't let her father die. Not if she could get him help. Which she could. She nodded firmly. "I will talk to Adora about that when she's coming over later today. Is he still in Washington?"

"His aide told me that Jacob rented a flat in Colorado Springs," General Hammond told her.

What? Was he planning to move to… to meet her? Something to ask him once he was healed. "Thank you, sir."

General Hammond nodded. He seemed relieved - but also worried.

"I don't think he'll hold it against you," she said. Truthfully, she wasn't sure - her father was prideful, after all. And stubborn. But General Hammond had saved his life in Vietnam.

"I hope so. But I can't let him die over some foolish stubbornness, Captain."

Sam nodded, although she had no doubt that the General wasn't merely talking about her father's stubbornness.

But that was Sam's business, not her commanding officer's.

When she had left the general's office, back in the hallway, in a moment of privacy, she closed her eyes and sighed deeply. Dad, dying from cancer… And he hadn't even told her!

*****

Sam was acting weird today, Catra had decided after the first five minutes in Stargate Command. The woman seemed distracted while they were talking about how to help Lenkova. Catra had mentioned that Lenkova needed a lover to recover, but while Adora had gasped at her, Sam had barely reacted. That was highly unusual, as they said - the woman's focus was good, but she still tended to react to such jokes at least with a frown or eye roll.

So, what was it that did this to her? Was she feeling guilty about something? Perhaps something related to Lenkova? Jealousy? Catra could understand that, of course. In hindsight.

If Sam thought that, with Lenkova recovered, the other woman would once again pursue O'Neill, using the sympathy bonus, as the humans called it, to win out over Sam, who was apparently hampered by their military's rules… Well, in her place, Catra would probably do a lot of stupid things, not just think about doing them.

On the other hand, Sam seemed more the type to throw herself into her work if she was struggling with jealousy instead of getting distracted. At least that was Catra's take on her - she hadn't reacted like this when Anise had been all but throwing herself at O'Neill (and Catra wouldn't be too surprised if the Tok'ra actually did that at the next meeting). In any case, Sam should just tell O'Neill that she loved him and settle this. If the rules didn't allow their relationship, they should change the rules. Hell, if Adora and Glimmer asked, the Americans might change the rules. Or add an exception for O'Neill and Sam. Whatever worked.

But if it wasn't her love life, then what had Sam so tied up?

"...and we won't be able to tell until the psychiatrists finish their preliminary evaluation, but that can't be done until she has recovered enough for a session," Sam said. "And she might react with hostility to such a proposal, anyway."

"Why?" Adora cocked her head to the side. "Aren't psychiatrists specialised in dealing with people suffering like her? Jack said something about a loony bin needing to make profits, but I thought he was joking…"

Catra nodded, although, privately, she was sure that, while Jack had been joking, he wasn't just joking but genuinely didn't like psychiatrists. He had made enough comments about shrinks for that. But that was a topic she wasn't about to touch.

Sam sighed. "If the psychiatrists come to the conclusion that she's mentally unfit for service, she'll be relieved from her post."

"Oh. And you think that the psychiatrists would be wrong." Adora nodded.

"I think they tend to underestimate our ability to deal with trauma and apply standards that are better suited for civilian occupations. But I am also aware that the distrust of psychiatrists that many soldiers have might lead to some of them hiding their problems for fear of being judged mentally unfit, ultimately becoming mentally unfit as a result of not getting help," Sam said.

That sounded like a quote or something, to Catra, at least. Not that it concerned her. And she didn't think Sam was worried about anything related to that either. Although… "Did they try to get you removed from Stargate Command?" she asked.

Sam winced before showing her usual calm expression. "After Jolinar's death, there were some concerns, mostly by psychiatrists without the necessary experience."

Catra nodded but made a mental note not to poke at that topic either. "But that's not what got you so distracted, is it?" she asked,

to change the topic - and to finally get to the bottom of this before Catra was driven crazy by not knowing.

Sam tensed for a moment, and Adora blurted out: "Distracted? Is something wrong?"

The woman sighed. "Yes. Although it's not related to Stargate Command."

"What is it? We can help! I think," Adora said. "We'll do what we can, anyway. You're our friend!"

Catra nodded in agreement - Adora would do what she could for their friend. Any friend, she added to herself with a smile.

Sam took a deep breath."It's my father. He's sick - cancer. Terminal cancer."

Adora gasped. "No! Where is he? I can go heal him right away!" She was out of her seat and turning towards the door before Catra or Sam could react.

"Wait!" Sam held up her hand. "It's not that… He's not dying right this moment. I mean, he's not in need of immediate healing."

"But…" Adora stopped but frowned. "Why should he keep suffering any moment longer than necessary? He's your father! Or are you worried about, ah, nepotism? With your father's life in danger?"

"No!" Sam closed her eyes for a moment and took another deep breath. "It's… We haven't talked for a while. We had a falling out a few months ago."

"Oh." Adora blinked. "That's…" She trailed off.

A falling out? With her father? Catra wondered how that would have happened. Was Sam's father like… like Shadow Weaver? Trying to control and manipulate her or something?

"He didn't know about Stargate. He thought I was 'wasting my potential in a dead-end posting'," Sam explained.

"Ah." Adora nodded.

Catra pressed her lips together. That did sound like a thing Shadow Weaver would have said. To Adora, of course.

"I'll still heal him," Adora said, nodding firmly.

Sam grimaced. "It's not... I mean, yes. But I want to talk to him before that. Alone."

"Oh, of course!" Adora told her. "Just tell us when I can come and heal him."

Sam winced once more.

Catra almost snorted - was the other woman shuffling her feet? Afraid to talk to her own father? Well, if he really was like Shadow Weaver, then Catra could understand that, of course.

But the other woman recovered quickly. "Alright, I'll contact you once that's… done. Now, about Lieutenant Lenkova…"

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White House, Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, December 6th, 1998

If he had known how many stupid meetings he would have to attend as a result of meeting the Tok'ra, Jack O'Neill would have buried Jakar in a cell and faked the paperwork rather than contacting the snakes. Well, no, he wouldn't have done that since that would have doomed Lenkova and Sha're, but he surely would have thought about it a lot. This was all the Tok'ra's fault for wanting humans as hosts!

"...and, in your opinion, Colonel, what kind of threat to Earth would the Tok'ra pose if they went hostile after securing hosts

from us?" the Secretary of Defense asked.

Jack had answered that question before. In his report, even - why was he forced to write those things if no one ever read them? But you didn't question the cabinet in the White House for not reading reports. Not as a Colonel. Not unless they were about to endanger Earth which they weren't. For now. "That depends on whether or not travel to and from their territory is restricted and under our control," he said with a polite smile. "And, if it isn't restricted and under our control, on what our rules of engagement are." They could track the snakes with enhanced Etherian sensors, but if the Tok'ra were guests of another country, things would get messy. Probably the kind of messy that Jack had been called to solve back in the Cold War.

"We control the Stargate," the Secretary of the Interior said. "But can we control space?"

"Not at the moment," the Secretary of Defense - grudgingly, in Jack's opinion - admitted. "We depend on the Etherians for that. But we can track any arrivals, and we have the capability to intercept spaceships in the atmosphere."

Jack frowned as he saw a few cabinet members nod. "You mean launching nukes," he said.

Several people gasped, and the Secretary of Defense glared at him. But the President nodded. "I don't know about everyone else, but I wouldn't exactly call using weapons of mass destruction on Earth a proportionate response to our allies letting people travel to earth whom we don't want here." He leaned forward, folding his hand. "Ladies and gentlemen, we are, and will be for the foreseeable future, dependent on the Etherians for anything related to control of space in this war. We haven't even laid down the first spaceships yet."

"No one on Earth has," the Secretary of Defense muttered.

“And our control of the Stargate is not complete,” the Secretary of State added. “It’s under the control of the United Nations, and while we have considerable influence in the Security Council thanks to our allies, we cannot expect to be able to unilaterally dictate who gets to use it and who doesn’t. Certainly not once it has been relocated to Canada.”

There was some grumbling about that, even though that had been a done deal for months now.

The President cleared his throat. “I know it’s a bitter pill to swallow, but we have to stop longing for the days when we were the undisputed superpower of the planet. Things have changed, ladies and gentlemen - drastically. The undisputed superpower on Earth is Etheria, and even amongst the countries of Earth, our nation is now merely one amongst the Great Powers. We need to adjust to that reality.”

“That’s temporary,” the Secretary of Commerce objected. “Our industrial superiority will restore the status quo once we have finished adapting to advanced technology.”

“The status quo has been irredeemably destroyed,” the Secretary of Education retorted. “Just because we have been the top dog for decades doesn’t mean we’ll return to that position. Demographics and geography can only carry you so far. We are talking about revolutionary technology that is transforming our entire world. The Europeans are already moving to drop their dependency on fossil fuels to take advantage of the new reactor technology the Etherians are sharing.”

The Secretary of Commerce snorted. “Good look trying to get that past the oil lobby!”

“Their oil lobby isn’t nearly as strong as ours. And they aren’t nearly as dependent on cars as we are, so the costs for them to change to this new paradigm is much lower - both political and financial,” the woman insisted.

“I didn’t know you took over my department,” the Secretary of Transportation sniped. “My experts certainly haven’t been able to make such predictions with any confidence.”

“That’s because they know you’re backed by the oil and car industry lobby and don’t want to upset you,” she shot back. “But the fact remains that we need to change a lot if we want to remain the most powerful nation on Earth. And we can’t do that by sticking to what worked before - and there are a lot of influential people who will fight any such change for entirely selfish reasons.”

“That’s just green propaganda! And the German car lobby has even more influence than ours!”

“But not on Europe as a whole!”

“Ladies and gentlemen,” the President repeated himself. “This is not the time to - civilly - debate our economic policies. We are here to discuss how to answer the Tok’ra’s proposals.”

Jack had to suppress a grin when he saw the reactions of the cabinet members to getting scolded. Not that it actually was funny, of course, to get such a stark reminder that the government didn’t know what to do yet. But you didn’t make a career in special forces without gallows humour.

“We can’t let them take over military personnel. Or anyone with classified information,” the Secretary of Defense said. “Also, we’ve come to the conclusion that any attempts to infiltrate them through trained operatives volunteering to become hosts are doomed to failure since they will literally read the operatives’ minds.”

“Colonel O’Neill, how do you think the Tok’ra would react to a spy becoming a host in order to access their technology and secrets?” the President asked. “Because while I agree that such a course of action would be foolish, I can think of a few countries who would take the chance.”

“Damn Russians and Chinese,” Jack heard the Secretary of Defense mumble.

“This is hard to say, Mr President,” Jack said. “The Tok’ra are, ultimately, a society of spies.” Thank you, Daniel, he added silently - his friend’s lectures on the subject were useful. “They will likely expect that. But we don’t know if they would consider it business as usual or an offence - or an opportunity to reach out to a country outside the Alliance for a separate deal.”

“If only to put pressure on us for more concessions,” the Secretary of State commented.

“And they have thousands of years of experience with such ploys - we have to assume they are aware of that possibility already,” the Secretary of Education added. “We cannot underestimate them.”

She was, of course, correct. The snakes, even if they were nominally allies, were damn dangerous.

“So, the best way to avoid all that is to provide the Tok’ra with as many hosts as they want,” Kinsey, who wasn’t a cabinet member but still present, spoke up. “And if they truly have such a close and intimate partnership with their hosts as you describe, Colonel O’Neill, then the more American hosts they get, the more they’ll share our views over our rivals’.”

That was just the kind of thinking Jack expected from Kinsey. This was like… a political human wave attack or something. He had to press his lips together to comment.

But the majority of the cabinet seemed to share the man’s views, nodding in agreement.

Damn.

“Of course, there are other ways to influence the Tok’ra,” the bastard went on with a smile. “According to my information, it seems a prominent scientist of them has become infatuated with you, Colonel.”

Jack went rigid. “The only thing Anise is interested in is my genes,” he snapped, glaring at the man.

“Isn’t that what most marriages are about, when it comes down to it?” Kinsey shrugged. “But, of course, I am not suggesting a marriage, or even a relationship, Colonel. I am merely pointing out that you have the opportunity to forge close personal bonds - of friendship - with the Tok’ra, as you did with the Etherians. Trust me, Colonel, we are all aware here that your and your team’s friendship with the Etherian leaders is a crucial factor in our relationship with the dominant power of this Alliance.”

Jack was so busy glaring at the scumbag, he almost missed the reactions of the cabinet. Almost - he didn’t miss the frowns on some people in the room, though. Or the surprise on the faces of some, which he really hoped was there because Kinsey was - dishonestly, of course - praising Jack and not because they had somehow missed the fact that for the Etherians, politics was based on personal relationships.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 6th, 1998

Each time Adora thought she understood Earth, or even just their friends from Stargate Command, they did something that left her confused. Well, not exactly, but it felt like this. Sam’s father was sick - deadly sick. Adora could heal him. But she shouldn’t be healing him right now because Sam wanted to talk to him first. That was kind of understandable - relationships with parents were complicated. Adora had no personal experience with that, having been raised without parents in the Horde, but she had seen Glimmer with Queen Angella and King Micah, and that was certainly a complicated relationship. At least with Queen Angella, but Glimmer had complained about her dad as well, though not as often. Bow had had some issues with his dads as well, but he didn’t complain about them nearly as often as Glimmer, so it probably wasn’t a problem. On the other hand, Bow tended to

keep things quiet… Anyway, Mermista's dad had run away from his kingdom in the middle of the war, leaving her to fight off the Horde almost by herself. And, of course, her other friends didn't have parents any more.

But what Adora didn't quite understand was why Sam wanted her to hide that she was healing her father - if her father accepted to get healed, of course, but why wouldn't he? He'd die otherwise! "They're so weird about this," she muttered under her breath.

Of course, Catra's ears perked up, and her lover turned away from the television in the room and cocked her head at Adora: "The humans?"

Adora looked around even though they were alone in the meeting room. Or waiting room, now that Sam was off to talk with her dad. "Yes."

"Of course they're weird." Catra shrugged. "We've known that from the start."

"No, I didn't mean…" Adora trailed off. "I meant about healing. Everyone knows I heal people if I meet them, and they need healing."

Catra nodded. "That's why we don't go shopping with you any more."

Adora glared at her. Her lover might be right, but that was still not a nice thing to say. Even if all the humans agreed that Adora's presence caused trouble or something. But it wasn't her fault that so many people needed to be healed!

Catra smirked in return, and Adora sighed. "But, as I was saying, the humans know that," she went on. "So, why do we need to smuggle Sam's dad into Stargate Command and heal him without anyone knowing?" Catra opened her mouth, and Adora held up a hand. "I know, they don't want to appear playing favourites."

"Well, that's the reason." Catra shrugged again. "Do you want to deal with everyone trying to become your friend so they or their family can be healed?"

Adora pressed her lips together. Of course, she didn't want to suspect her friends of using her like that! But no one should feel forced to do such a thing anyway because they had no other choice. "But we are playing favourites, aren't we?" And it was obvious to anyone - there had been some official complaints by other countries, Adora knew, about favouring the USA.

"Of course we are," Catra replied. "Would you want to let a friend die just because you can't save everyone? That would be stupid."

Adora nodded. You can't save everyone, so you should not save anyone? She couldn't believe some people on TV had actually said that! That wasn't how you did things! You did what you could to help people!

"And the humans also do it. They just use excuses, such as 'improving the efficiency of the government by ensuring that key members of the administration aren't distracted by health issues or health issues of their immediate family'," Catra went on.

Adora groaned at the reminder. Her suggestion that they could just gather everyone in the same room or hall and let her heal them had been turned down 'for security reasons'. And for the same 'security reasons', she was supposed to hide healing the government. Or governments. "Why would the people have a problem with their leaders getting healed?" she complained. "They elected them! If they wanted them to die, they shouldn't have voted for them!"

"Perhaps they want them to suffer?" Catra shrugged with a chuckle.

Adora scoffed. If your leaders were suffering, they couldn't really focus on leading. And that dragged everyone down. That was

basic knowledge any cadet was taught. “That would be stupid of them.”

Catra nodded in agreement before turning back to the TV, where the news was covering the unveiling of another new factory project in… Detroit?

Adora had missed the announcement, and the buildings all looked alike to her. Not that it mattered, as long as it distracted her from thinking about the whole thing. And from thinking about whether or not Shadow Weaver had been a parental figure or not.

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Colorado Springs, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 6th, 1998

Samantha Carter took another look at the apartment complex in front of her. It wasn’t much of a complex - it looked more like a converted small two-story motel. To think that Dad would be living here while he was deathly ill and not in a hotel! He certainly could have afforded a hotel. Was this an attempt to be subtle? Or did he have money trouble? She hadn’t really kept up with the family finances, but a general’s pay, while quite generous for government employees, wouldn’t prevent you from ruining yourself through a few foolhardy investment decisions. Maybe she should have asked Mark if he had heard anything, but her brother might wonder why she would be calling, and if he got involved before she had Dad’s cancer dealt with…

Sam clenched her teeth. She was stalling, she realised. Trying to delay the confrontation. And she was better than that.

Straightening, she stepped forward, headed to door number five and rang the bell. Which was newer than the door and looked like it had been added as an afterthought. Definitely a converted motel, then.

It took about fifteen seconds until she heard “I’m coming!”, and the door opened.

And Sam was looking at her father. Who was staring back at her for a moment, mouth open, before recovering from his surprise. He looked thinner than she remembered him. Chemotherapy? He still had some hair. Same male balding pattern.

She took a deep breath. “Hello, Dad.”

“Sam.” He nodded and took a step back. “Come in.”

She nodded in return and entered the small apartment, trying not to feel as if she was stepping into the office of a superior.

The apartment was barely larger than General Hammond’s office, but it did have room not only for an armchair to watch TV but also a small desk turned into a table with two chairs. Sam refrained from commenting on the spartan furniture - she was here to get her father healed, not to start a confrontation.

“Have a seat.” He gestured at the desk.

Nodding again, she sat down, and he followed suit, putting the table between them.

“You’re in uniform,” he said.

“I came directly from the Mountain.”

He frowned slightly. “Who told you?”

“That doesn’t matter.”

“It was probably George, wasn’t it?” He snorted with a twisted smile. “Trying to save my life again.”

Sam clenched her teeth. “It doesn’t matter. What matters is that you have inoperable cancer.” She leaned forward. “I’ve arranged for healing by the Etherians.” There. Short and to the point.

She saw his eyes widen, the edges of his mouth twitching as he relaxed for a moment, before a familiar frown appeared on his

face. “I didn’t ask for preferential treatment!” he snapped back. “Or nepotism.”

Nepotism? Sam suppressed a gasp. Was this what this was about? Oh, he was… “This isn’t about using your influence to get a relative a posting, but about saving a life!” she snapped.

“It’s the same principle!” he retorted. “Why should this be different?”

“It’s about your life!”

“And it was about your life!”

“No, it was about my career!” She glared at him.

He scoffed. “We’re both career officers, Sam. The military is our life.”

“That’s… That’s not true!” There was more to life than your career.

“Really?” He cocked his head. “And what’s your life outside the military?”

Not that again! “If you want grandchildren, visit Mark!” she spat.

His lips turned into a thin line.

“Sorry,” she pressed through clenched teeth. “I shouldn’t have brought him up.” Her brother’s estrangement from Dad wasn’t why she was here, and bringing it up wouldn’t do any good.

He slowly nodded. He didn’t apologise for *his* remarks, though.

It didn’t matter. She was here because her father was dying and she could save him. Would save him. “As I said, I have asked the Etherians to heal you. You might as well accept it,” she added with a forced snort. “I doubt that you could stop Adora.”

“Did you think what people will say about this? They’ll accuse you of abusing your position for personal gain.”

“They already accuse me of exploiting my friendship with them,” she shot back. “And who cares? I don’t want you to die, Dad,” she added in a softer voice.

“And I don’t want you to sacrifice your career prospects - or your principles - for me.”

Oh, the stubborn old fool! Sam had to take a deep breath and force herself to calm down to keep from lambasting him. “My career isn’t in any danger,” she said. She was, without any false modesty, the best scientist Earth had for researching Ancient technology and magitech. She wasn’t entirely sure if she would even be allowed to resign her commission if she wanted to.

“You say that, but I’ve seen good officers get cashiered for petty reasons. Or as scapegoats. Just being my daughter is enough to earn you the enmity of people who can’t get to me.”

“Removing me from my post would wreck key projects for national security,” she retorted. “Not to mention it might damage relations with our newest ally.”

He frowned again. “Are you serious?”

Sam nodded. “For the Etherians, politics are personal. They take friendships very seriously. If I get fired for petty politics, they won’t just shrug and continue business as usual - they’ll question whether or not they can trust America.” She hesitated a moment, then added: “And I could easily get hired by them and continue my work. With far less interference by the brass.” Though she didn’t know if the Etherians would formally hire her - she hadn’t asked how they handled such things, she realised. But she had no doubt that she would be welcome amongst them for as long as she wanted to stay.

“You would join the aliens?” he seemed surprised.

“Yes, Dad. They are my friends.” It would also allow her to continue working with SG-1. And she wouldn’t be bound by the

regulations concerning personal relationships any more either… Best not go there.

He nodded. “I see. I didn’t know that.”

She swallowed the bitter ‘there’s a lot you don’t know about me’ comment that this prompted. “Yes, Dad.”

“But it’s still…”

“It’s your life, Dad,” she snapped. “And it’s how the Etherians do things.” With another snort, she added: “Just accept it before they make a diplomatic issue out of it.”

He chuckled, but she wasn’t entirely joking. Adora felt strongly about family. “I guess I have no choice then? If you’re sure it won’t hurt you…” He trailed off.

Not nearly as much as you dying would, Sam thought. Out loud, she said: “It won’t.”

“Alright then.” He sighed and seemed to shrink a little as he slumped, and suddenly, he looked far sicker than before. Tired. Exhausted.

Sam felt the urge to get him to Adora as soon as possible. “Then let’s go.”

“Right now?”

“They’re waiting for you,” Sam explained.

“You’ve got the leaders of an alien planet waiting to heal me?” He stared at her. “Queens and princesses?”

“I told you - they’re my friends, and they take that seriously,” she said. “They’d have the president himself reschedule a meeting for this.”

He blinked, and Sam fought the urge to smirk at him. That would have been petty.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 6th, 1998

"Dad, these are Adora and Catra. Adora, Catra - my father, Major General Jacob Carter."

Sam's father didn't look much like his daughter, Catra thought. At least not at first glance. In his favour, he didn't stare at her ears and tail like others - though that hadn't happened very often lately. Although they also had restricted their visits to diplomatic and military meetings and close friends. People who knew better than to stare at her. Or were used to her. The general had a firm handshake for a human, though, even if he looked frailer than others. She nodded at him. "Hi there."

"Hello!" Adora beamed at him.

"Hello." He looked around. "So, this is your lab. With all the alien technology."

"Yes, Dad."

"One of her labs," Adora added after a moment of silence. "Entrapta and Sam also built a spacelab."

"So, you achieved your dream of going to space."

"Yes."

More silence. Catra rolled her eyes. If that was how you acted with a father, she didn't want one.

"So, where do you want to be healed?" Adora asked. "I can do it here. Or we can go to the infirmary so Dr Frasier can observe it with her instruments."

“Whatever is more convenient.”

“We should do it here,” Sam said. “Fewer witnesses.”

“Rumours will spread anyway,” her father complained.

“Not on our end,” Sam retorted.

They were arguing again. Catra shook her head. “Just spread more rumours. Silly ones, so people won’t believe any rumour for a while.” She had done that a few times as a cadet. It hadn’t worked all the time, but it had generally been amusing.

Sam frowned at her, but her father laughed. “What do you have in mind?”

“Dad!”

“Come on, Sam - you almost smuggled me into the base in your trunk.”

“I did not! I was merely discreet.”

“Well, you could spread rumours that you needed, uh, to talk about…” Adora trailed off.

“An arranged marriage? Grandchildren? A teleporter so you could visit more often?” Catra suggested.

Sam glared at her - she should be used to such humour, in Catra’s opinion, the way she pined after O’Neill - and her father laughed some more.

Not for long, though. He grew serious soon enough. “I think ‘family matters’ should suffice. People will make up their own rumours anyway. And I can visit George afterwards.”

“Sounds good,” Catra agreed.

Sam grudgingly nodded, which sealed it.

“Good!” Adora beamed at them again and summoned her sword. “For the Honour of Grayskull!”

This time, General Carter stared, but Catra couldn’t really fault him for that. She had seen it a hundred times and still enjoyed the sight herself. The magic. The power. Adora.

Adora didn’t lose any time after transforming, pointing her sword at the man right away - as if she feared he might change his mind - and let the magic cover him.

Catra saw the general stagger, gripping the edge of the table next to him to steady himself even as Sam rushed forward.

Then he blinked. “Wow. This…” Shivering, he stretched.

Sam had frozen halfway to grabbing him when he recovered and now pulled out a scanner and pointed it at him. “Let me check!”

“I healed him,” Adora told her with a pout. Not that Sam would listen, in Catra’s opinion. Not when it was her father getting healed.

“This is…” The man started moving, rolling her shoulder, raising his arms. Then he bent down, slowly, carefully at first, before doing a squat, then two. “The pain’s gone.”

“Yes,” Adora told him. “All the microdamage is healed. You’re perfectly healthy for your age now.”

“I certainly feel like it.” He smiled, though he still looked a little… unsure? Shocked? Catra found it hard to tell.

“The scan confirms it,” Sam said. “No anomalies.”

“Anomalies?”

“It’s magic, Dad. Better be safe than sorry.”

“I won’t, ah, suddenly grow fur?” he asked with a glance at Catra. “You didn’t mention possible side effects.”

“You were dying, Dad!”

“Don’t worry! I haven’t changed anyone since Swift Wind!” Adora tried to reassure him. “I know how to control my magic now.”

“Good.” The general’s grimace was soon replaced with a smile again. “But even if I transformed - this feels great! Thank you!”

“You’re welcome.” Adora nodded with a smile.

Catra leaned back against the wall next to her. One problem solved. And they had something to tease Sam about now. Something safer than her feelings for O’Neill. “She’s a bit like Glimmer and Micah,” Catra whispered. Just a bit, though - there was more tension there, but she was, in some way, as concerned about his health as Glimmer was about Micah’s. With more justification, of course. Micah wasn’t deadly ill. Hadn’t been deadly ill either.

“And like Glimmer and Angella were,” Adora added in a low voice.

Catra winced. Angella was trapped in another dimension because of her. Because she had been an idiot and a maniac willing to risk the entire world to get what she wanted. Which she could have gotten anyway if she hadn’t been an idiot. Damn.

“Oh…” Adora reached out to hold her hand.

And it seemed as if Sam’s father had noticed her reaction as well.

Fortunately, Catra was saved from explaining or lying.

“Carter? You won’t believe what Kinsey did this… Ah, good evening, General Carter.”

Catra’s ears twitched as O’Neill actually snapped to attention and saluted. She grinned - that was interesting.

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Diplomatic Meetings Part 3

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 6th, 1998

"Hello, Colonel O'Neill."

Jack O'Neill wished someone would have told him that Carter's father, *Major General* Jacob Carter, was at Stargate Command before he entered her lab to complain about politicians in general and Kinsey in particular.

"Hi, Jack!" And Catra was grinning widely. Damn.

"Hello, Jack." Adora, at least, was her usual friendly self.

"Colonel." And Carter was... annoyed? Or concerned.

"What did Senator Kinsey do this time?" the general asked.

Jack didn't really want to answer that. Not just because it was a little embarrassing; that wouldn't prevent him from sharing a story with a general - it wasn't as if he really felt intimidated by them, after all. But it concerned a meeting in the White House. And while Jack trusted his team with his life, so trusting them with his career was easy, the general wasn't quite that close. And he was *Carter's* father.

So Jack sighed. "He had some interesting ideas about interstellar diplomacy, sir. Unfortunately, they were discussed in a meeting with the President and the cabinet, so I can't share any details."

The man, who looked far too fit for his age, raised both eyebrows. "But you were about to share them with my daughter?"

"Well, they, ah, concerned her." Jack kept smiling. "She wasn't mentioned by name, though, but it included her as well."

"Really." The general didn't look mollified.

And neither did Carter. “What did he say, sir?” she asked in a clipped tone.

Time to backpedal. “He had some comments about politics and personal relationships. With aliens.”

“What?” The general looked confused. As did Adora. Carter was still frowning. Even more so, now, actually. And Catra…

…was grinning. “Oh, did he propose some diplomatic marriage for you?”

“What?”

“What?”

“What?”

“He was joking,” Jack replied. “I think so, at least - you never know with politicians like him,” he added before he could help himself.

“He better be joking,” the general hissed.

“Dad, a marriage of state isn’t on the table!” Carter could sound remarkably like her father if she was angry, Jack noticed.

“We don’t do marriages of state!” Adora shook her head. “We marry for love!”

“Glimmer would kill anyone who tried to make her marry someone for diplomatic reasons,” Catra agreed with a firm nod. She seemed serious, Jack noted.

But Carter still looked angry. “Was he talking about abusing our friendships for political gain, sir?”

Jack winced. He couldn’t really deny that.

“I thought so,” she hissed.

Adora was frowning as well. “Friendship shouldn’t be abused.”

Catra nodded and didn’t make a cynical comment - to Jack’s surprise. Then again, maybe he should have expected that from her; she seemed to value her friendships more than pretty much anything else. Except for Adora, of course.

“Well..” he shrugged. “I think everyone who matters knows we wouldn’t do that.” At least, he hoped the President was aware of SG-1’s stance on that. Or listened to advisors who were, like General Hammond. Instead of to Kinsey - that slimeball had too much influence, in Jack’s opinion, because he could manage the conservatives. “Anyway, more importantly, it looks like the government will not deny the Tok’ra their main request.”

“They’ll let people volunteer to become hosts?” Carter tilted her head.

“Yep.” Jack nodded.

“Good.” Adora smiled again. “If someone wishes to enter such a relationship with a Tok’ra, they shouldn’t be denied.”

“I assume that this is limited to people without classified information,” the general said.

“Yes,” Jack said. After a moment’s hesitation, he added: “The idea is that we’d rather have Tok’ra sharing American minds than, say, Iranian.” In for a penny, in for a pound, as the Limeys said. And he didn’t think that the general would tattle. Not now.

“Ah.” The general nodded. “That makes sense.”

“Yes,” Catra agreed.

“And what if the Iranians want to volunteer?” Adora asked.

“That’s the thing the government hasn’t figured out yet.” Jack shrugged. Time to change the subject. “So, what brings you to the Mountain, General?”

“Family business, Colonel,” the general replied smoothly. But Carter looked tense, and Adora guilty.

Jack suppressed a grin. That was interesting.

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Adora bit the inside of her cheek so she wouldn’t blurt out the truth. But why did the general lie to Jack? Well, technically, it wasn’t a lie - it was kind of family business, but that was the kind of word games Shadow Weaver would have played. Adora could understand that they didn’t want everyone to know, but Jack was a friend. A close friend - and he was even closer to Sam than to Adora and Catra. Lying to your friends, or just not being honest with your friends, was a bad idea. Adora knew that from personal experience.

“Ah?” Jack tilted his head. “I won’t pry then.”

Adora didn’t think Jack was telling the truth right then. And she didn’t think General Carter and Sam believed him either. But both nodded.

And then Jack smiled at her. “So, what have you been up to, Adora?”

“Ah…” Adora struggled not to grimace. “Well, we’re…

“Unfortunately, my father’s not cleared for that,” Sam cut in before Adora could mention that they were waiting for Lieutenant Lenkova to wake up so they could talk to her - which was another ‘technically not a lie’ that Adora didn’t like.

“Yes,” the general agreed. “Need to know and everything. I’ve got the clearance for a lot more these days, but since Stargate Command is no longer an Air Force project but run by the United Nations, that doesn’t mean as much any more.”

“Well, technically, we can tell whoever we want what we want, as long as it concerns us,” Catra pointed out with a grin.

Adora frowned at her lover. That was true, but this wasn't the best moment to mention it.

Sam's father chuckled. "Ah, yes, it's often hard to remember that you're actually your country's highest authority and not just another soldier."

"Well, Adora is - arguably. I think Glimmer could argue that," Catra said. "But I'm just another soldier. Technically without an official position. Not that we care much about that."

"You're like a princess," Adora retorted. Everyone better be aware of that! Catra was one of those amongst the Alliance who had the most experience leading an army. Granted, it was the Horde army, but still!

"I'm no princess," Catra shot back. "And I don't have a country to rule."

"Netossa and Spinnerella don't rule a country either," Adora pointed out.

"They are princesses, though. And they were leaders in the Alliance before Horde Prime attacked." Catra shrugged. "It doesn't matter anyway since I'm not going to leave your side."

Ah. Adora couldn't help smiling at hearing that. Even though she knew that Catra's talents were, well, not wasted, but underused if she just stuck with Adora. Catra had almost defeated the Alliance, after all, when she had been leading the Horde. "Well, that doesn't mean you won't get a command," she said. "I could come with you, for example!"

"And who would I command? Former Horde troops?" Catra snorted.

"The clones would follow you," Adora retorted.

"If you tell them to." Catra rolled her eyes.

Adora nodded. “Well, yes. They’d still follow you.”

“And they’d still look to you for orders.”

That was… well, Catra was probably correct about that, Adora had to admit.

“How exactly is the Alliance organised?” the general askedwith a frown.

“The Princess Alliance or the Alliance?” Catra grinned.

“The Princess Alliance. I’m aware of how the Alliance is organised.” The general sounded… not mad, but more serious than Adora had expected.

“Well, the Princess Alliance generally has a big meeting, everyone talks too much, and then we do what Adora and Glimmer want,” Catra said.

“Catra!” Adora scowled. “That’s not how it works!”

“That’s how it works out.” Her lover shrugged. “If you and Glimmer want to do something, or don’t want to do something, who’s going to make you?”

“Sort of like the United States were in NATO,” Jack added with a grin. “And now the shoe’s on the other foot.”

“It’s not quite like that!” Adora insisted. “We do make decisions as a council.”

“And most listen to you and Glimmer,” Catra said. “Which is a good thing, of course. Well, Netossa isn’t bad, either. But I’d rather not have Mermista lead our campaign. Or Perfuma. I’ve conquered both their kingdoms with the Horde, so I know how bad they are at leading people.”

“One of the drawbacks of hereditary monarchies,” Jack said. “People who shouldn’t be leading get to lead.”

“They’re not that bad,” Adora defended her friends. But Catra was correct - Mermista and Perfuma were not the best officers in the Alliance. Well, not when it came to strategy. But.. “They’re very effective on the battlefield.” Thanks to their magic, of course.

But this war would be fought in space, where there was no water or plant life to control - and on a scale where individual actions wouldn’t be as important. Adora hoped her friends back on Etheria understood this.

“That makes them good soldiers,” Catra retorted.

She was right, but there was more to it. “Perfuma and Mermista also have the support of their people,” Adora pointed out.

“Still doesn’t make them good strategists, but yeah, I guess that will be a factor in the war.” Catra shrugged.

Adora took that as a victory in their argument. But it also reminded her that they hadn’t heard of Etheria in months She hoped that Entrapta’s bots would soon finish the communication relays to Etheria so they could talk to them and fill them in about what had happened so far. Adora really wanted to know how her friends were doing.

Perhaps they should have used part of the fleet as relays - then they would have had communications much sooner. But that would have strung out quite a few ships doing nothing but keeping station, and the bot network was safer and more effective.

Well, that was how it was in war - almost every action had some drawbacks. “Let’s talk about Lieutenant Lenkova,” she said to change the subject.

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“So, now you’ve met the Etherians,” Samantha Carter said while walking with her father to General Hammond’s office. It was a safer topic for the hallways than their family, and walking in

silence would have been awkward - and would have started even worse rumours than were probably already going around.

"Oh, yes." Dad chuckled. "I think I understand now why Boeing, Lockheed and Northrop were bothering me lately."

"They were bothering you?" Sam frowned. Why would they… Ah.

"Lobbyists," Dad confirmed her deduction. "They usually aren't that bad - I'm not in procurement - but I thought they had stepped up their efforts with everyone amongst the brass. But no - that was because of you and your friends." He chuckled again. "What irony!"

"They want you to use my friendship with the Etherians for their own goals?" That wasn't amusing, in Sam's opinion. It went against everything she believed in. Although she felt a little hypocritical now that she had used said friendship to save her father's life. But that wasn't the same thing.

"Of course. There's lots of money to be made in research and development," Dad said. "Especially in the aerospace sector. Any company that gets those contracts has it made. And any company that misses out is basically done for. The stock of the smaller manufacturers is already crashing since everyone thinks shuttles will replace helicopters and aeroplanes tomorrow or maybe the day after tomorrow, and they don't expect anyone but the biggest firms to manage that."

Sam hadn't followed that very closely. "That makes no sense. It will take years, probably decades, to replace every helicopter and plane currently in service. And the militaries will have priority," she pointed out when they stepped into the lift.

"The stock market isn't really sane - it's all about what people think. Or what analysts think people think." Dad shrugged. "The car companies are feeling the same pressure. People want flying cars for Christmas at the latest."

Sam snorted. Even in wartime, research and development cycles weren't as fast. And this was about the civilian market. "They'll be disappointed."

"Not just them. A lot of people will be disappointed," Dad said. "No one knows yet how the war economy will work out. And how the rest of the world will be affected. Worst case, wars will break out over the changes the new technology brings - General Watson is already wargaming some conflicts in the Middle East in case some of the oil states decide to deal with their rivals before they are rendered obsolete and go bankrupt. I think they're running a betting pool on the country most likely to start it, but I've been out of the loop lately."

Because he had been dying. Sam nodded. "You can't just switch from a fossil fuel-based economy to an economy based on advanced technology in a few years."

"But it won't take too long either," Dad replied as they stepped out of the lift. "You can replace power plants easily enough once you can build new ones."

Leaving obsolete power plants full of dangerous substances - radioactive in the case of nuclear power plants - to be cleaned up. At least, that would occupy a lot of people who would be out of a job otherwise.

"In a way, the war's a blessing," Dad said as they approached General Hammond's office. "It'll make transforming the economy easier since we'll have to produce so much for the military. That will make up for the loss of civilian production. Somewhat, at least."

But it wouldn't help those businesses who couldn't get into the military market, Sam knew. Or those countries cut off from advanced technology.

Further discussion was cut off when General Hammond's aide announced them.

"Jacob! Captain Carter!" General Hammond greeted them. "Come in, Jacob. You too, Captain."

They stepped into the office.

"You're looking good," the General commented.

"I'm feeling great," Dad answered the unspoken question. He rolled his shoulders. "And I've got to thank you for that, I've heard. That's twice you've saved my life now. I need to step up and make it up to you."

The General laughed - relieved, Sam realised. Well, Dad could show a temper, as she knew from personal experience. "I just passed the news along."

"Still…" Jacob nodded at his friend.

Hammond nodded back.

"Well, it worked out," Sam commented. "And with the possible exception of Colonel O'Neill, I think the odds of anyone in the base figuring it out are low."

"And even if they do, we'll manage," General Hammond said. "So, you've met the Etherians. What's your take on them?"

"They were much less formal than on television," Dad replied.

"They're not as formal in planning meetings either," General Hammond said.

"A logical consequence of their culture, sir," Sam pointed out. "As ruling monarchs, they obviously don't act like career military." Daniel had covered that often enough, but Dad hadn't read those reports.

"It'll take some time getting used to that… informality, I guess," Dad said. "That who you know and are friends with matters more than your rank… well, to some degree, that was the case already."

Hammond nodded with a small scowl. “Yes. It helps with cutting through some red tape, but it also gives the Etherians an even greater influence on the Alliance.”

“If we don’t pay attention, we’ll have our own command structure wrecked,” Dad agreed. “And discipline degrades as everyone runs to the next princess to work around orders they don’t like.”

“It’s not quite as bad,” Sam objected. “They do have military experience.” But he was correct about the fact that Earth couldn’t afford to run things like the Ethrians did. “I’ll mention the concerns to them, though.”

Dad was staring at her. Oh.

Sam pressed her lips together. She was still a military officer and scientist, first and foremost. Not a diplomat or politician.

But in a war, you did what you had to.

*****

“You’re concerned about military discipline breaking down because of us?”

Adora sounded flabbergasted, in Catra’s expert opinion. Perfectly understandable, of course - the only reason Catra wasn’t also staring at Sam with her mouth hanging open was because she had been looking at another scout bot prototype when Sam had started talking and had recovered faster.

“It’s a concern. Nothing has happened yet, but…” Sam sighed. “We do things differently on Earth. You may have noticed that we’re not quite as informal as you are.”

Catra cocked her head sideways. “Really? Do you shoot soldiers for disobeying orders as well?” She remembered seeing that in some movies, but those were supposed to show historical wars and generally had the bad guys doing this.

“We might do that in wartime, depending on the severity of the offence.”

“We’re at war,” Catra pointed out.

“Yes.” Sam frowned.

“SG-1 isn’t very formal,” Adora said. “Jack’s quite informal. The only one from your team who calls him Colonel is you, actually.”

Sam didn’t blush, but she tensed for a moment, Catra noticed. “That’s because I’m the only other member of the team who’s a soldier,” she told Adora. “I can assure you that the other teams are more observant of military forms and regulations.”

“Oh.” Adora nodded. “Yes, SG-3 was like that, I think.”

“Yes,” Catra agreed. “Still less formal than the Horde.”

“I don’t think the Horde is a good comparison point,” Adora told her. “It kind of makes formality sound like a bad thing.”

Catra shrugged. “Unlike the Alliance, we didn’t have any princesses, so it comes closest to the situation on Earth.” They had had Scorpia, but she hadn’t been a princess back then. Or acted like one. Then again, she had made Force Captain…

“The United States Armed Forces aren’t the Horde,” Sam said firmly. “But yes, we don’t have princesses. Or other nobility. We don’t have, ah, people who were born into leadership positions. Our leaders in the military derive their authority from their earned rank.”

Catra suppressed a scoff. She doubted that every officer had actually earned their rank - people were always promoting their friends and cronies. But overall, it was a good point. “And the officers don’t like it if people don’t follow the chain of command.”

“Yes. It can undermine their authority,” Sam confirmed. “The superior officers tell their subordinates what they have to do but

leave it up to them to decide how they do it. And they report to them, not to others."

"That works with good subordinates who can handle the situation. But sometimes, you need to take charge of a situation as supreme commander," Catra said.

"Yes," Adora agreed. "And you need to check on your subordinates. They might not be telling you the truth about how they're doing."

"That's a different problem. What we're concerned about is soldiers starting to ignore their superiors to go directly to you or your friends," Sam said.

"And taking up our time with petty problems and complaints." Catra nodded. She could see that happening. It hadn't happened in the Horde, of course - you only annoyed a superior with that kind of bullshit once before you learned your lesson, unless you were Kyle - but she had seen princesses personally taking care of small issues in the Alliance.

"Exactly. And if a superior does this often, they'll undermine their subordinates' authority."

"Right. But we won't do that," Adora said. "Don't worry!" She beamed at Sam. "We won't step in more than necessary."

But the other woman was worried. Catra could tell. And she had a point. Kind of. "I expect that we'll be moving around too much, anyway, to disrupt your discipline too much," she added. They would be dealing with hundreds of thousands of troops - millions in the long term. "Your officers will be able to restore discipline easily enough." Once whatever Catra or others had had to do had been done, of course. "But you might have to talk to Glimmer about this. She's the one who grew up in the Alliance."

"Yes. I will have to," Sam said. She didn't sound too happy. But that wasn't Catra's problem. Glimmer could sort that out.

*****

Lenkova still looked bad, Catra thought as she saw the woman in the mess hall. She appeared healthy, at least physically, but her whole body language… If she had a tail, it would be dragging on the floor, and if her ears could move, they would be drooping. And she was sitting alone at a table. By choice, Catra was sure - it was between lunch and dinner, so none of the regular shifts was eating. None of the Russians, at least. Though Catra didn't think that Stargate Command would leave the woman unsupervised after what she had gone through, so… Ah, there were the soldiers keeping an eye on her.

"She looks so sad," Adora commented next to her.

Catra glanced at her and rolled her eyes. What did her lover expect? Adora had seen Catra after they had freed her from Horde Prime's control.

Adora blushed. "Sorry."

Catra shrugged. It had been her own fault, after all. "Let's go talk to her." Without waiting for an answer from Adora or Sam, she sauntered over to Lenkova's table and plopped herself down in the chair across from her. "Hey!"

Catra had taken care to approach Lenkova from the front, so the woman wasn't surprised; you didn't startle soldiers who looked like that. She glanced at Catra, Adora and Sam before returning the greeting. "Hello."

"Hi!" Adora said with a forced smile - Catra could tell.

"Hello, Lieutenant," Sam added.

"I take it you are not here by chance," Lenkova commented. "This is what you would call an intervention?"

Catra grinned. "Right in one!"

“It’s not an intervention, but yes, we’d like to talk to you,” Sam explained. “We know at least part of what you’re going through, trust us.”

Lenkova nodded, though it was obvious that she didn’t. Trust them, that was. “Here?” she asked, making a point to glance around.

“In private,” Sam explained.

After a moment, Lenkova nodded. “Yes.”

Catra looked at Lenkova’s food, which had been barely touched - and it was the good dessert, according to O’Neill. In return, the woman scoffed and got up - and dumped the food on the way out. What a waste!

“That would have started a riot back in the Horde,” Catra commented on the way to the lifts.

“What would?” Lenkova asked.

“Dumping the food,” Catra explained. “Of course, just offering such food - dessert! - would have started a riot anyway.”

“Oh, yes. We never got dessert in the Horde. Or anything else than grey and brown rations,” Adora nodded.

“You could get other food if you knew the right people,” Catra objected.

“That would have been against regulations!” Adora shook her head.

“That sounds like you needed better quartermasters,” Lenkova commented. “Or less corrupt ones.”

Catra noticed that Sam looked as if she wanted to say something about that, but the woman just pushed the button in the lift, taking them down to her lab.

“Well, I wouldn’t call them corrupt…” Adora started to say.

“I would,” Catra interrupted her. “They were making deals with each other.” Often, it had been frustrating to try and get the needed supplies for an operation, though that had been mostly due to Hordak, and later Entrapta, requisitioning things for their projects without regard for the Horde’s need. But the quartermasters had been rotten anyway.

“Well, yes, but the thing is, regulations never covered other food, only rations. So there was no way to actually get dessert.” Adora blinked. “When we wanted to celebrate, we had cake made of the good rations, actually.”

They reached their floor and stepped out of the lift.

“You sound like old soldiers in the Red Army,” Lenkova said as they approached Sam’s lab. “They were telling such stories as well whenever the younger soldiers were griping, to show how much worse they had it back in the days.”

Ah, the woman thought they were telling tales? She didn’t know Adora then; Catra’s lover was honest to a fault. Catra chuckled. “That’s not the point of this,” she said, stepping past Sam into the lab.

“And what’s the point?” Lenkova dropped her fake polite smile as soon as the door closed behind them and looked at her with narrowed eyes.

“I spent years leading the Horde, fighting the Alliance,” Catra told her. “Whatever mistake you’re worried about, I made much worse ones.” Starting with not following Adora when she asked her to, back in that stupid village, Thaymor.

Lenkova’s eyes widened, but she recovered quickly. “That doesn’t make me feel better.”

“It shouldn’t. It’s supposed to make you realise that fucking up isn’t the end of the world.” Catra shrugged.

Now the officer frowned at her. “I know that everyone makes mistakes. But mine caused the loss of my team. Two of my men dead. One captured. And…” She pressed her lips together.

“You were taken over by a Goa’uld.” Once more, Catra shrugged, though she had to force herself to act nonchalantly. “I got taken over by Horde Prime. He had chips that allowed him to take control of others - make them obey his orders. And he could jump into you to take control of your body. Speak with your voice. Act with your hands. I attacked Adora.”

Lenkova stared at her. “I see. How long?”

“A few days.” An eternity when being controlled. And tempted to just accept it. Accept the mindless peace and bliss that was offered. If Adora hadn’t come for her…

“And you got over it.”

Catra shrugged again. “With the help of my friends.”

“And we’ll help you,” Adora cut in. “We know what you’ve been through - well, some of us.”

“I was possessed by a Tok’ra,” Sam said. “Jolinar.”

“I know. I was briefed about that,” Lenkova said. “And yet, we are supposed to ally with them?”

Oh. Catra hadn’t expected that - this wasn’t just about the Goa’uld.

“The Tok’ra oppose the Goa’uld,” Sam said.

“They still take over people. They are the same… the same species,” Lenkova retorted.

Catra briefly wondered what she had been about to say. Monsters? Aliens? It didn’t matter. “So?” She asked. “They didn’t

do anything to us. They freed you," she added, feeling a little guilty when the other woman flinched.

"And they don't force themselves on others - they ask for a partner," Adora said. "They're not the same as the Goa'uld."

"Yes." Sam nodded.

"They did force you. I've read the report." Lenkova glared at Sam.

"That was an emergency," Sam replied. "But yes, I was possessed. And my body was taken over. I know how it feels. How you feel." She raised her hand, but only a little, then let it drop to her side again.

Lenkova clenched her teeth. Hard - Catra could see her jaw muscles twitch. "And the memories?"

Sam winced. "Yes."

"But if yours were from a Tok'ra who only forced itself on people in an emergency, you don't understand." Lenkova shook her head. Almost violently. "I have memories… of a monster. So many crimes. Atrocities. Torture. And it liked it. I remember loving it."

Oh. She had been possessed by a Goa'uld working at a bioweapon research facility. Catra nodded. "But those aren't your memories."

"They feel like it. When I dream, I can't tell who I am."

"Yes." Sam grimaced. "But that will get better. I know that. It's bad, but it will get better. Trust me."

Lenkova didn't look like she did but nodded anyway.

This could've gone better, Catra thought.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 7th, 1998

Jack O'Neill hated politics. And politicians. Most politicians. Some were OK. Probably. And you shouldn't hate the President, your commander-in-chief. Unless they deserved it. But overall, he would really prefer it if he could just do his job and not deal with politics.

On the other hand, he wasn't quite sure if briefing another bunch of politicians - something that Daniel could do much better, but, apparently, he was a bit too honest for them, or so Jack thought - wouldn't be preferable to talking to Lenkova. If Carter, Adora and Catra hadn't managed to do any good - and Carter's report had been pretty pessimistic - then what could Jack himself do? Well, he should be able to do as well as Catra, though that was a low bar unless the girl hadn't been as brash as usual.

But Lenkova was one of his, and Jack knew his duty. Any officer worth their commission put his people first. Always.

So he knocked on the door of Lenkova's room - she had been released from the infirmary - and waited.

After about fifteen seconds, just long enough to start worrying that the shrink who had dismissed the suicide watch had been wrong - he heard her call 'enter' through the door.

He stepped inside and caught the woman tugging on the hem of a grey Air Force sweater that clashed some with her Russian-style camo pants and… sandals?

"Colonel O'Neill." She shifted to a parade rest position despite her off-duty attire. Well, she was off-duty until further notice.

"Lieutenant Lenkova." He nodded.

"Please have a seat." She pointed at the only chair in the room.

Sitting while a woman was standing wasn't how you did things in America unless you were behind your desk and dealing with a subordinate who had messed up. But refusing would be impolite and send the wrong impression, so Jack sat down.

Fortunately, Lenkova took a seat on her bed. Though Jack didn't fail to note that she sat ramrod-straight and was as tense.

"So, how are you doing?" He cocked his head.

She relaxed a little, but he caught her frowning for a moment. "I was released from the infirmary, Colonel," she replied.

He had dealt with that kind of evasive answer before and raised his eyebrows at her in response.

She was about twenty years too young to stand up to him and pressed "I am well considering the circumstances, Colonel" through clenched teeth.

"Meaning, you're blaming yourself for stuff that wasn't your fault and dealing with memories of a snake in your head." He nodded. Just talk casually. Professionally. As if this was a normal situation and he perfectly knew what he was doing.

"Yes, Colonel." Now that was a smile. A cynical one, and quite twisted, and probably not very healthy, but a smile.

He smiled back. "So, I'm supposed to tell you that it wasn't your fault and that it'll get better if you just believe in yourself." He shrugged. "Too bad."

That confused her. She blinked, then stared at him.

He grinned. "I was never really good at following orders to the letter. Especially when they don't make too much sense." Not that they were orders, but Jack knew what was expected of him. But he also knew that trying to copy Carter and the others wouldn't work since they had tried that before.

"So, what are you here for, Colonel?" she asked. She was frowning openly now, which he took as a good sign.

"Well, I'm telling you that as the officer in charge of your men, they were your responsibility." He met her eyes and saw her

flinch. “Yes, even if there’s nothing you can do, you’re still responsible. That’s what being an officer means. It’s not fair, but life’s not fair.”

She nodded slowly, hesitantly. “Yes, Colonel.”

“And I’m not going to bullshit you and claim things will be fine. Things will get better, but you’ll always remember your mistakes and the people you lost.” Like Kawalski. Or Charlie.

“Yes, Colonel.”

“So, I expect you to do better next time.” He nodded at her. “But that means I expect you to find out what you could have done better and improve, not wallow in guilt.”

“Yes, Colonel.” She looked… well, not better, but determined. Good enough, he guessed.

“About the snake memories…” He shrugged again. “Not much we can do. They’ll fade over time. And they aren’t your memories. But they might be useful intel, so, if you can, write down what you remember before you forget.”

Her eyes widened in surprise before she pressed her lips together - probably blaming herself for not seeing that angle.

Jack nodded, hiding how guilty he felt for manipulating the woman. But giving her a task she could do, a way to strike back at those who hurt her, an objective, would allow her to keep going and, ultimately, get over this. Find more reasons to keep going than spite. Or so he hoped.

At least, it had worked for him, after Charlie.

He still felt like a slimy politician when he left her room again.

*****

NATO Headquarters Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 8th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and several unions have announced strikes to protest the closing of factories in…"

"...and well, those riots in France might look bad, John, but compared to prior riots, those are really nothing to write home about - or, in this case, to report. The core of the riots seems to be made up of recently laid-off workers, and as long as they do not receive more support from other parts of the population, this won't be more than an episode, so…"

"...stock market remains volatile as prices wildly fluctuate depending on the latest news. Analysts are concerned about the lack of information regarding further steps of sharing technology. Magic remains a wild card, as the recent meteoric rise and subsequent fall of several pharmaceutical titles showed in response to completely unsubstantiated rumours that they had recruited sorceresses for medical research, but…"

"...while the citizens of Detroit are looking forward to the new shuttle factory, Boeing reported a series of cancelled orders from airlines and has denounced the new European Investment and Armament Program as an illegal attempt to subsidise its main competitor, Airbus, citing…"

"...of the Green party presented a new concept for a car-free city based on advanced alien technology…"

"...spokesperson of CERN announced the complete restructuring of the current organisation to focus on advanced technology…"

"...Bundeskanzler sagte, er habe vollstes Vertrauen, dass die Deutsche Autoindustrie sich an die veränderten Rahmenbedingungen anpassen werde, wobei aber mit kurzfristigen Verwerfungen zu rechnen sei…"

"...of the government of Norway stated that in light of the reveal of new power plant technology, Norway is reconsidering its focus

on oil production. When questioned, he confirmed that the country is planning to use its statens pensjonsfond to finance the transition of their economy to one based on advanced technology…"

"...OPEC members apparently are divided about the best course of action, with some countries favouring to take what profits they can while the global economy still relies on oil and others pushing to use the threat of reducing oil production to force concessions from the industrialised countries to 'ensure the future prosperity of our countries in a world without oil'. The United States government released a statement that such an 'artificial shortage of crucial resources' would harm the war effort and would receive an appropriate response, but refused to go into details, and…"

"...and these shocking videos of lynchings of gay people in Iran, with the police not only tolerating these murders but actively aiding, raise concerns that the Etherians might intervene to stop those atrocities. What do you think, Connor?

Well, Bob, so far, the Etherians have shown immense restraint considering the shocking disparity of power, but one can only wonder how long this will last if those countries - and I include more than just Iran here - blatantly commit atrocities. Yet…"

Adora pressed her lips together. "We need to do something," she said as the TV in the meeting room showed shaky footage of two people being dragged through a crowd.

"Glimmer's putting pressure on the United Nations," Catra replied, switching through a few entertainment channels. "She said harsher sanctions were on the way."

That wouldn't stop the murders any time soon, though. Adora knew that much. Some countries were under sanctions for decades without changing their policies. "It's not enough!"

"What do you want to do instead? Invade?" Catra raised her eyebrows at her.

“No…” That would, at least according to SG--1, cause even more atrocities as many other countries would panic. And they didn’t have the troops to garrison a country, much less an entire region of Earth. “But we can’t let them just do this!” It wasn’t right.

Catra sighed. “I know, But what can we do? Take out the government?”

That would have the same results as an outright invasion. Too many governments would be afraid to be next. Adora clenched her teeth. “It’s so frustrating!”

“I know.” Catra smiled sadly at her.

The door opened, and Glimmer entered. “What’s wrong?” she asked as soon as she saw their expressions.

Catra pointed a the television. “Take your pick.”

Glimmer scoffed. “As I keep being assured by our allies, Earth is actually doing better than expected, overall.”

“That’s too bad for those who do worse, I guess,” Catra said.

“Yes.” Glimmer sat down at the table and grabbed a soda from the basket in the middle. “But we can’t really do much about it. Not without making things a lot worse.”

“We shouldn’t let them get away with those crimes!” Adora blurted out. “They keep murdering people for… being like us!”

“Yes.” Glimmer looked grim as she nodded. “We’ll bring it up in the next Alliance meeting. Once we are finally done with our response to the Tok’ra’s proposal.” She groaned. “So, sometime in the next ten years or so.”

“That bad?”

“They’re fighting over details. Even though the main issues have been settled. Don’t ask me how, though - first, no one wanted to

send any volunteers, but now, suddenly, everyone wants to send as many as possible." Glimmer shook her head.

That was good news. But… "And what can we do about that?" Adora asked, pointing at a news report showing a massive riot somewhere.

"Why are they rioting?" Glimmer asked.

"Dunno," Catra told her. "Either they are afraid of losing their jobs, or they are afraid of people being able to live and love like they want."

"We can't do much about the first problem," Glimmer said. "We're doing what we can to share technology, but Earth has a hard time adjusting, and we can't trust everyone. The second… apparently, the best we could do is accept as many refugees as possible, according to our allies." She scoffed again. "It seems a lot of people would feel a lot better if most gay people emigrated to Etheria or anywhere else off Earth."

"Even our allies?" Adora asked.

"They aren't open about it, but the way they talk about 'immigration pressure' and other stuff…" Glimmer grimaced.

"That's not right! No one should be forced to leave their home just to be able to love whom they want!" Adora protested. "Can we take them in, anyway?"

Glimmer winced, which wasn't a good sign. "It depends on how many people would go to Etheria. Earth has so many humans…"

"It's a mess," Catra commented. "They should settle some empty planets and spread out."

"That's looking like a good solution," Glimmer agreed to Adora's surprise. "But we don't have the resources for that. We've got enough trouble preparing for the war."

"And if Earth had the resources to settle other planets, we'd be spread rather thin protecting them," Catra aded.

That was true. Which meant they would have to let the lynchings continue.

Adora hated feeling powerless in the face of such evil.

*****

Diplomatic Meetings Part 4

NATO Headquarters Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 9th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter couldn't help feeling that while, without question, having access to shuttles that could take you around the world in less than an hour was a great thing, there were drawbacks. Such as the fact that if you could reach every point on Earth in less than an hour, people adjusted their expectations accordingly.

Which resulted in her being flown to Brussels to provide advice to the Alliance meeting currently held there. And not technological advice - or not primarily - but personal advice.

"...and you think we can trust the claims of the Tok'ra that they won't force themselves on unwilling hosts, Captain Carter?" the German minister present asked.

"I think they are honest in that they won't do that unless circumstances such as an emergency force them to resort to such means," she replied.

"So, despite your own experience, you trust the Tok'ra?" The man seemed honestly surprised.

"*Because* of my own experience," she corrected him.

And then wished she hadn't done so in such a pointed way when the man nodded and said: "Yes, we can see that."

Glimmer spoke up before Sam could find the best words to respond to the insinuation that she was influenced by the Tok'ra: "You have been briefed about the effects of Tok'ra - and Goa'uld - possession. The mental contamination is restricted to various amounts of fragmented memories. Their hosts, once freed, are not under their mental control any more."

“But we also have reports of lingering effects,” the French Ministre des Affaires étrangères cut in.

“Yes,” Sam told him. “But not to the extent that they would compromise my judgement.”

Most of the ministers present nodded, though Sam wasn’t sure that all of them believed her.

“And you called Sam here precisely because she had the memories of a Tok’ra in her head,” Glimmer added. “Are there any other questions for her?”

There were none, and Glimmer quickly added: “I move that we recess for ten minutes.”

To Sam’s mild surprise, everyone agreed, and she found herself leaving the meeting room with Glimmer.

As soon as they entered the meeting room that was occupied by the Etherians for the duration of their stay in the NATO headquarters, Glimmer sighed and sat down in the closest chair. “I’m so tired of this!”

Sam nodded, even though she wasn’t entirely sure what Glimmer was tired of - she hadn’t followed the state of the negotiations very closely.

“Sorry about that, by the way. They insisted on questioning you,” Glimmer added as she opened her eyes and pulled the basket with soda bottles closer to her using her staff.

“You already apologised when I arrived,” Sam pointed out while she grabbed a bottle of mineral water for herself. “At least I got to check out the new shuttles,” she added.

“Ah, yes.” Glimmer shrugged - of course, she wouldn’t be impressed by the first piece of advanced spacecraft built entirely on Earth. “Anyway, sorry. I think a few of the ministers are stalling

because their governments are still trying to make deals with each other, and you were a convenient excuse."

"Ah." That sounded plausible, in Sam's opinion, but she had no way to tell if it was true.

Glimmer took a swig, swallowed and sighed. "Anyway, how are you doing? Entrapta was all gushing about your spacelab."

Sam smiled for the first time since she had started answering questions in the meeting. "It's quite useful. We can cooperate a lot more this way." And there were much fewer safety concerns now.

"Good." Glimmer took another swallow. "Also, Adora told me that you think we might corrupt your military discipline."

Sam suppressed a wince. "It was mentioned to me that there is a concern about the chain of command suffering if high-ranking officers go around it."

Glimmer snorted. "I don't think your generals pass every order to a soldier through their entire chain of command instead of giving it directly."

"No," Sam admitted. "It was more a concern about subordinates going around their commanders."

"You mean going to Adora and myself," Glimmer said.

"And other princesses, I think."

Glimmer sighed again. "That can't really be helped. A princess is expected to take care of problems - within reasons, of course - if asked to by their people."

"Do you consider Alliance soldiers your people?" Sam asked.

"Well…" Glimmer took another swig. Was she stalling? "In a way, yes. I mean… it's sort of a grey area. In the Princess Alliance, you

generally don't meddle with soldiers from another kingdom; they got their own princess to look out for them. But if that princess is not available, you're expected to step in if needed. And, well… you don't really have princesses, so…" She shrugged.

"...so your first instinct is to act as if you would back home," Sam finished for her.

"Yeah. I mean, we wouldn't do it if it's a stupid complaint or concern, but sorting out problems with subordinates is what princesses are expected to do. It's part of being a ruler." Glimmer smiled. "I'll brief the others that this is a sensitive subject with Earth."

That wasn't as reassuring as it could've been, in Sam's opinion. Maybe she should ask Daniel about this.

*****

NATO Headquarters Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 9th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and I have to point out that when the Tok'ra are looking for hosts, they are looking for life-long partners. This is an extremely personal and intimate choice for them; they will not adhere to some sort of… contingent assigned by us. Would you pick your partner according to a quota?" Glimmer's scowl made it clear to everyone that this was a rhetorical question.

Then again, after some of the proposals they had heard today, Catra wouldn't have put it past some of the Alliance members to suggest exactly that. The news had speculated about marriages of state being proposed, referring to unnamed sources within one of the delegations, and Catra wasn't entirely sure that those sources were fictional. A few of the politicians in the Alliance still seemed to have trouble accepting that Etheria's princesses were different compared to Earth's royalty.

"Yes, yes," the French minister said. "Although we can and should take steps to ensure that the Tok'ra are giving everyone a fair

shake, so to say. We do need to decide on how we present the volunteers anyway, to avoid complications and misunderstandings."

"What do you mean?" the American representative asked with a frown.

"I want to make sure this is not going to be handled as 'first come, first served', the French politician explained with a smile that was about as honest as Shadow Weaver's, in Catra's opinion. "If we created such incentives to rush the selection of the volunteers, we would put Earth's security at risk."

"The United States won't flood the Tok'ra with our own volunteers if you wanted to insinuate something like that."

"I did not, but it is good to hear."

Yeah, the smiles were a bit too toothy to be honest and friendly. Although it was getting late by now, and Catra was sure she wasn't the only one getting hungry again - dinner had been a while ago.

"In that case, I move that we settle the details later," Glimmer said. "Perhaps after inquiring with those who have experience hosting such events."

"I don't think anyone on Earth has experience with such an event," the German minister commented with a snort.

Glimmer shrugged. "Everyone mingling and looking for a partner at a social event - doesn't that sound familiar?"

That caused a few chuckles, with Adora joining in a little late - Catra's love had started nodding in serious agreement before she got the joke.

Although it wasn't really a joke, Catra realised. Holding an event like the Princess Prom seemed to be a much better idea than lining up volunteers to be inspected like livestock or something. Or

having a bot play matchmaker, as Entrapta proposed - as a joke, or so Catra hoped.

But with the meeting finally winding down, Catra stretched, relieved, and didn't bother hiding her yawn.

"Catra!" Adora hissed.

She snorted in return. "It's almost midnight."

"But still…"

But Glimmer was already ending the meeting, and Catra quickly rose from her seat. "Let's get a snack on the way home!"

"Oh… alright," Adora caved.

Glimmer kept smiling until they were in the questionable privacy of their waiting room, where she sighed. "This was worse than most meetings of the Princess Alliance."

"You handled the thing well," Catra told her, cocking her head while she opened a pre-packaged sandwich.

Glimmer scoffed. "Not as well as I could've handled a Princess Alliance meeting. I don't know the humans well enough."

"Not yet," Adora commented.

"Probably not ever," Glimmer said, grabbing a soda for herself. "They keep changing ministers and generals even without elections."

"But we only see most princesses at the Princess Prom," Adora pointed out.

"But we see those who matter far more often. And they don't get replaced on a whim," Glimmer complained. "Anyway, let's go home. I want to cuddle with Bow and have him tell me I am doing important work, so I don't teleport the next idiot into the ocean."

Catra chuckled. Whether Glimmer was joking or not, it was funny. And cuddling with your love sounded like an excellent idea.

At least they had finally settled the proposal for the Tok'ra. More or less, anyway.

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P34-353J, December 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Another day, another planet," Jack O'Neill commented after stepping through the Stargate.

He had his M4 in his hands, even if he wasn't aiming it at anything or anyone - this wasn't supposed to be a hostile planet, and the Tok'ra had sent the codes to indicate that it was safe, but you never let down your guard when you were in alien country. Especially if you had been attacked on the planet before. And if you had civilians to guard. Or shepherd. Civilians who made Daniel look like a special force soldier.

"Colonel O'Neill. Queen Glimmer. Princess She-Ra." Martouf nodded at them in turn. "Captain Carter. Welcome."

"Martouf." Jack nodded back, but he wasn't relaxing. The snake wasn't just politely smiling at Carter. There was something more there. As before, actually.

And Carter looked a bit tenser than normal. "Martouf. Lantash."

"Hello!" Glimmer smiled her polite smile.

"Hello." Adora beamed at the assembled Tok'ra.

"Hey." Catra, though, nodded and kept scanning the area. And she wasn't particularly subtle about it.

In any case, it seemed safe. Jack used his radio to signal Stargate Command to send the actual diplomats through. Well, the actual diplomats from Earth - Glimmer and the others were diplomats as

well, after all. And officers. And monarchs. Most of them, at least. Jack wasn't sure if he should envy or pity them for that. Probably both.

A few seconds later, Daniel and Teal'c stepped through the gate, followed by Emily and Entrapta, and then the first of the diplomats arrived, escorted by SG-2.

Martouf didn't seem to mind that they had brought more firepower than usual for a diplomatic mission, but then again, if your diplomats included magical space princesses who could throw tanks and turn spaceships into plants, a few killer robots and soldiers probably didn't make a difference.

Which would be a wrong thing to think, of course. But Jack didn't mind being underestimated. In fact, he preferred it.

"Hello," the leader of the delegation, a British diplomat who wouldn't look out of place in a Monty Python movie, in Jack's opinion, said, giving Martouf a bow. "I am Sir Watson, representing the Earth part of the Alliance."

"Hello. We are Martouf/Lantash. Please follow us - we'll take you to the meeting area." Martouf pointed to the skiffs waiting in the back.

At least none of the diplomats with Sir Whatshisname gawked at the hovering vehicles. That would have been embarrassing.

But, Jack thought as he saw Martouf paying extra attention to Carter, he really had to get to the bottom of this. If his second-in-command was being hounded by an alien, Jack would have to do something about it. Couldn't have snakes messing with his team.

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They arrived at an unfamiliar spot in the desert - the Tok'ra had built a new base, it seemed. Or simply moved the location for the transporter pickup, but Jack O'Neill's money was on the former. This was a negotiation, after all, and they would be showing off

the technology they knew the Alliance was interested in. Like some arms dealers he had had to work with in the past.

The Tok'ra weren't a front for Russians supporting insurrectionists, Jack reminded himself. They were fighting the Goa'uld, not a proxy war against the United States. He still didn't like them, and it had nothing to do with the way Martouf was smiling at Carter when they stepped off the second vehicle.

"Please stand by for the transporter."

And here it came. Jack tensed a little as the rings appeared around him.

And then he was inside a room, underground. And the air smelt… better than a bunker's air had any right to smell. No wonder the Tok'ra were so fond of creating new bases.

"Colonel O'Neill!"

Jack suppressed a frown and nodded as politely-but-distantly as he managed. "Anise."

The snake was beaming at him. "And Freya," she added in a human voice. And that was the host. She had a whole different body language, he noted. The woman moved more like a human instead of a well, smooth snake. But the look she gave him was the same - and belonged in a bar at happy hour, not at a diplomatic meeting. "How have you been, Colonel?"

"Oh, the usual. Paperwork. Lots of paperwork," Jack claimed nonchalantly. "Boring paperwork in preparation for this mission."

"Ah." Freya nodded with an empathic smile. "A necessary evil."

Then Anise continued: "Documenting your research is, of course, the hallmark of any scientist worth their education, but filing reports for the ones in charge of your budget does get tedious and often frustrating."

“I wouldn’t know about that,” Jack replied - wasn’t it a diplomatic gaffe to talk to the escort at such meetings? But Garshaw was talking to Glimmer, Adora and Sir Watson. Damn. “I’m just the guy with the gun guarding the diplomats and scientists.”

“Oh, you are much more than that, Colonel O’Neill!” Anise cooed - and Jack discovered that a snake voice cooing was much creepier than he had imagined. He definitely preferred the creepy megalomaniac snake voice to this.

But they were on a diplomatic mission, so Jack couldn’t just tell the snake to get lost. Even worse, his team and his friends had noticed - not that this was hard to miss even for Daniel - and were looking amused. Well, except for Carter, who wasn’t amused. Probably because it looked unprofessional, Jack told himself. Even though it wasn’t his fault this time. Hell, even the diplomats had noticed! If any of them told Kinsey about this, Jack would shoot them.

Just when he suspected that Anise was about to grab his arm and try to drag him off to some lab or bedroom - and Jack didn’t know which possibility he would find more disturbing - Garshaw spoke up, addressing everyone. “Please follow us to the meeting room. Your guest rooms are adjacent to it, and we’ve prepared a light meal before we start the negotiations.”

Food sounded great right now. Jack might even go for a drink. On second thought, no - he needed all his wits to deal with the snake trying to seduce him.

*****

Adora smiled fondly when Catra stacked her plate with all sorts of fish and almost fish dishes. Things were going well so far. The Tok’ra were friendly, and since the Alliance had decided to grant them their greatest demand, more hosts, they should be able to get them into the Alliance. Preferably as part of a new alliance between Etheria, Earth and the Tok’ra. A Triple-Alliance? They would have to sort out the exact name later. Adora didn’t think

that the Tok'ra would join as another member state like the individual countries on Earth, even if Earth might want that. Earth just had too many people for that.

"Jack's playing with fire," Catra commented after wolfing down a few pieces of fried fish.

"Eh?" Adora turned her head to look at what Catra was nodding at. Oh. Jack was talking to Anise, who was very close to him - she was almost touching the plate their friend held before him. And he had his back to the wall. "It looks more like Anise is bothering him," Adora commented with a frown.

"He's not doing much to push her away," Catra retorted. "And Sam's mad."

"Oh." Right, Sam didn't look happy. But was that because of Jack or Martouf, who hadn't left her side since they had arrived? Adora couldn't tell. Their friend was often glancing towards Jack, but that might be because she expected him to do something about Martouf. Maybe - the whole situation was needlessly complicated because of these stupid American regulations. She should really talk to the President about that… No. That would be meddling with their friends' love lives, and that was a bad thing. All the human TV shows agreed about that, too. And there was another point to consider, Adora realised. "He probably doesn't think he can push her away without being rude, and that might damage the negotiations."

Her lover scoffed. "If the Tok'ra don't understand that Anise is being rude, then that needs to be settled before we form an alliance."

That was true, of course. Jack shouldn't have to feel uncomfortable like that just for politics. Or worse. But… "Maybe we should do something."

"No," Catra objected. "This might be the thing they need to finally stop avoiding their feelings."

Her lover was serious, Adora realised. “You’ve been watching those weird TV shows again?”

“Huh?” Catra seemed confused. Or tried to appear so - her tail gave her away.

“The ones the Japanese gave us as a gift?” Adora raised her eyebrows. “With the catgirls?”

“Oh.” Catra shook her head with a grin. “I was saving them for us to watch together. Should be funny.”

“Oh. OK.” Adora didn’t push. Catra’s interest in how humans saw people like her was understandable, even though the humans had never met actual people like her. But those shows were, well, weird.

“Oh, look! Sam’s doing something! Oh, smooth!”

What? Adora turned her head again. Oh. Sam was talking to Entrapta. But… Ah.

Adora smiled when Entrapta went to fetch Anise, and she, Sam and Anise quickly started huddling together in a corner near Emily, who served as a holoprojector.

“She got rid of Martouf and Anise in one smooth move.” Catra nodded - and then pouted. “But she’s still avoiding the real issue.”

Yes, Adora thought, Catra really has watched too many TV shows, weird or not.

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“...and if we adapt this piece so it can be powered by magic, we should be able to increase the efficiency by at least 75%. As a rough estimate.”

Samantha Carter nodded at Entrapta’s suggestion. That would solve the power issues of their current proposal.

"If your numbers are correct - and I bow to your experience in magitech here - then yes, that should allow us to run several crystal arrays simultaneously," Anise agreed. "Though I can't provide details about the exact specifications until we have finalised the treaty."

"Of course." Sam nodded. This was merely hypothetical. Theorycrafting, so to speak. It was still enjoyable and productive. Far more so than watching Anise trying to seduce the Colonel. Or watching the Colonel let the Tok'ra all but crawl into his lap. Really, he should know better than that! Sam suppressed a frown. And a wince when she reminded herself that she hadn't really told off Martouf herself - but then, her… Jolinar's former lover hadn't been nearly as obvious as Anise, and he had lost his love, so putting him on the spot would have been very rude.

And this was a diplomatic meeting. Not some… other meeting. Even though some aliens might be mixing them up. On the other hand, the Tok'ra were looking for more hosts most of all, so maybe this was a sort of marriage meeting…

Sam nodded again as she studied Entrapta's next proposal to improve the tunnel-growing technology based on what their scans had shown. As long as no one expected her - or the Colonel - to get involved with any of this, that was none of her business.

And that was how she liked it. She was a soldier in the United States Air Force. She knew her duty. And she knew that the regulations governing her life were there for a reason. An excellent reason.

Even though she really loathed them sometimes. But that wasn't something she could change. Not unless a lot more things changed - for her and SG-1.

She forced the gloomy thoughts away and focused on the topic at hand. Advanced technology was something she could deal with, at least.

*****

"...and while we see no reason to object to our people volunteering as hosts, we do hope that you will understand and respect our security concerns with regard to how such hosts are then chosen by you," Sir Watson said with a smile that Catra would have considered genuine if she hadn't been at half a dozen meetings where this had been hotly, very hotly, debated. "There should be enough suitable volunteers from amongst our population, anyway."

More than enough, in Catra's opinion - Earth had a stupidly high population. That was something that the Tok'ra agreed with. Some of them hadn't even believed the numbers they were told until Anise had run a few simulations. Apparently, the Goa'uld were deliberately keeping their slaves' numbers from rising too high to avoid another rebellion like the one on Earth thousands of years ago.

Though Catra had her doubts about the theory that sheer numbers of rebelling slaves had been the defining factor for pushing the Goa'uld off the planet. Numbers counted for a lot, but her bet was still on powerful magic. She had fought the Princess Alliance often enough - far too often - to know that the Horde would have crushed any number of the rebel soldiers if not for the princesses and the few sorceresses who had not hidden in Mystacore or one of the kingdoms not involved in the war. Although the Princess Alliance also had had access to far better technology than Earth, especially thousands of years ago, had had.

Adora squeezed Catra's thigh - and not in the teasing way. In the 'pay attention' way Catra was so familiar with from countless boring lessons as cadets. She snorted softly and patted her lover's hand, digging her nails into Adora's skin just a little - it wasn't as if anything important was being discussed right now.

"...although the exact conditions for choosing hosts have to be determined. This is a highly personal decision, which cannot be

delegated, so…”

Yeah, Per’sus was just saying what Glimmer had been saying for days. And Catra didn’t really care about how the Tok’ra wanted to do the matchmaking. That was none of her business - as long as none of the little snakes tried to go for Adora, of course.

Oh, Glimmer was standing up to talk. Catra’s ears tilted forward a little.

“I agree with Per’sus, and I suggest that any volunteers - after being vetted by the Alliance - will meet the Tok’ra at a location of their choosing, although for security reasons, they will not travel alone.”

Catra half-expected the Tok’ra to make a comment about the Alliance not trusting them with security, but they just nodded in agreement. Probably didn’t think they could object after their first meeting with the Alliance had almost ended with a Goa’uld spy blowing them up.

Catra snorted softly again. If that was what it took to run such meetings more smoothly, they needed more such spies.

*****

Jack O’Neill would really love to have a Goa’uld attack right now. Or any attack that gave him an excuse to ditch the meeting and go shoot something. Or comb the desert for a possible spy. He was so sick of people arguing over minor details.

Of course, how the Tok’ra contacted potential hosts from Earth wasn’t exactly a minor detail, given all the security concerns involved. And the diplomatic concerns on Earth since if they used the Stargate for transport, the Russians and Chinese - hell, the rest of the United Nations - would want in as well, and telling them off would piss them off. More than they already were. And probably have them look for ways to mess with the whole project - or infiltrate it. Or both. Though they would likely try that anyway. And if they held the host matchmaking meeting on Earth,

they would have to pick a suitable location that was acceptable for most members of the Alliance without causing security concerns - no one wanted a snake, friendly or not, loose on Earth. Or kidnapped. Jack's bet was on Canada - close enough to the USA and Europe while not being the USA.

OK, some important concerns were being discussed, he admitted grudgingly to himself. It was still damn boring. And, more concerning, it was apparently boring enough for Anise to focus on him instead of on whoever was talking. At least she was too far away - separated from Jack by Carter and Entrapta - to actually talk, but the glances she kept sending him… If she was using her alien scanner to see through Jack's clothes, he would have some words with her.

He blinked. That might actually be a real concern. He would have to ask Carter about that - but how, without sounding like a… well, sounding like he was actually worried about alien peeping toms.

"...and with that, I think we could use a break from negotiations."

"I concur. We have refreshments and snacks prepared in the room next to this."

What? Already? Jack blinked. That was…

"Colonel O'Neill!"

And Anise came at him like a Sidewinder locked on his engine. Carter got up to intercept her, but the snake was focusing on Jack. "I would like your opinion on how demographics affect the war strategy."

Oh. That was a safe topic - unless they started talking about personally doing your part to increase demographics. So Jack shrugged as they were walking to the buffet next door. "Well, the Goa'uld still have us outnumbered with soldiers, but the numbers of soldiers don't count nearly as much as the number and quality of spaceships." Who controlled the air - or space, in this case -

controlled the war. Usually. Vietnam came to mind as a counter-example, of course.

He relaxed a little as he picked up a glass of fruit juice from a tray at the door. Talking about strategy and tactics was something he could easily do.

"Well, according to your claims - backed up by the evidence so far - your ships are technologically superior to the Goa'uld ships," Anise said after taking a sip - more like a gulp, actually - from her own drink. "But numbers are crucial; the Goa'uld fleet is spread out, which facilitates defeating them in detail, but it also allows them to strike at many, many targets - in addition to the attacker's advantage of picking when and where to attack. And, unlike us, you have worlds you cannot easily evacuate and have to defend. That's a strategic liability."

"Yes." Jack nodded. No need to lie about that. "But in order to attack a world, you must first know where it is. And while they know about Earth, Etheria is not known to the Goa'uld." And the planet had only recently returned to this universe according to the Etherians - something Jack still had trouble understanding or even accepting. Sticking an entire solar system, planets, moons and *sun*, into a pocket dimension? It was mind-boggling!

"But you still need to guard it anyway, just to be safe. The political cost of exposing it to danger, much less the blow should it be lost, allow nothing else. And, of course, the Goa'uld will quickly learn of its existence once the war switches to open invasions. If they manage to capture an Etherian, they might even gain enough information to find the planet," Anise retorted.

Jack nodded, hiding a frown. He wasn't talking to a snake version of Entrapta, he reminded himself. Anise had the experience and background of a spy as well - and knew politics much better than Jack's friend.

But Anise's interpersonal skills were still a bit less than impressive, he added mentally when the woman shot him another look that

was far too obvious and added: “But I am sure a man of your talents has solutions ready for such problems.”

“Well, I’m not in charge of strategy,” he said, raising his glass. “I’m just a colonel in Stargate Command.”

“Not for long, I would hope.” Anise looked him over again. “Surely your government realises what a waste that would be.”

“I quite like it where I am,” Jack said. “I’ve got the best team possible, and I do very important work. And other people are better at the paper-pushing thing. Strategy and logistics,” he added when he saw her frown. “You know, the thing that wins wars.”

“Do not sell yourself short, O’Neill. You are a very experienced and skilful warrior. Did not General Hammond comment that you could expect a promotion in the future?” Teal’c gave honest but completely unwanted praise.

And, of course, for once, Anise deigned to acknowledge Teal’c, nodding. “Exactly!”

“That still won’t put me in any position where I could move fleets around,” Jack pointed out. “I won’t even be in charge of Stargate Command.” At least, he hoped so.

Anise drained her glass. “That is a pity. On the other hand, if you are not burdened with such a high position, you have much more freedom to take part in missions - or other projects, correct?” She beamed at him,

Oh, Hell and damnation! Jack had absolutely no doubt what kind of ‘projects’ Anise had in mind. “Ah, I need another drink. I’ll be right back!”

He glanced around as he went to refill his glass. Carter was talking with Entrapta and Martouf and not even looking in his direction. Daniel was talking with Per’sus. Adora, Glimmer and Bow were talking with Garshaw and Sir Watson. And…

“Just tell her you’re not interested.”

…and Catra was standing at his side, refilling her plate. She sounded bored, too, but that was probably feigned.

“That would be rude. And you know what they say about a woman scorned,” he told her.

“No? What do they say?” She cocked her head, then plopped a fried piece of fish into her mouth.

“Hell hath no fury like a woman scorned,” he quoted… he didn’t actually know who had written that. Shakespeare?

To his surprise, Catra nodded in apparent agreement. “Oh, yes.” Why was she…? “So, why are you risking such fury by flirting with Anise?” she asked.

Jack blinked. What did she…? He pressed his lips together to avoid lashing out at the insinuation.

And she sighed and shook her head. “You really need to sort this out. Trust me, I know.”

He knew she wasn’t just talking about telling Anise to stop hitting on him. But she didn’t understand. Things were complicated. And against regulations. They were in the middle of a war - which would heat up soon - and they couldn’t afford to wreck the best team Stargate Command had. Or disrupt… He shook his head. This wasn’t like whatever Catra and Adora had. It was completely different. If this was even a thing at all - it wasn’t as if he had talked to Carter about anything. But even without anything being said, there were moments…

“There is nothing to sort out,” he snapped - knowing it was a lie.

Catra shook her head and turned away, headed back to Adora and the others.

*****

"...of course, this tunnelling technology is very useful, but it can be replaced by conventional tunnelling techniques, while magitech opens entirely new fields of study - and more applications - so I do not think that an exchange with Ancient technology would be equal."

Adora frowned - Sir Watson did sound genuine, but what he said went against what she had heard about the Tok'ra technology from Bow and Entrapta.

"Even leaving aside the potential inherent in adapting the technology to other fields, as well as the sheer value for building infrastructure on planets you have just taken, I think you're undervaluing the fact that our technology, while based on Ancient technology, is not gene-locked to descendants of the Ancients," Garshaw retorted.

"Yes!" Entrapta piped up, nodding several times. "Working with this technology is much easier, from a researcher's point of view, than with First Ones technology. Sometimes not as interesting, though," she added with a pout.

Sir Watson didn't frown, Adora noted, but his smile grew a little more… polite. "Earth has the ability to produce prefab housing and bases. The differences in efficiency might be significant, of course, but not as significant as space superiority."

"But in order to take advantage of better FTL drives on a strategic level, you need to be able to produce ships in large numbers. We are limited by population and industrial capacity," Garshaw pointed out. "Advanced technology could improve existing ships, but that would mostly facilitate some operations, not change the balance of power."

"You could use your technology to quickly set up yards, though." Sir Watson nodded.

"Those would still require a workforce that we cannot provide and tooling we lack at the moment, and even with both requirements

filled, we'd be talking years to show the first results."

"We can help out there! We did that for Earth's shuttle factories - bots are working there while the humans learn how to produce the designs!" Entrapta smiled widely.

"And we already agreed to let people volunteer as hosts, so that should cover the numbers you currently lack." Sir Watson added.

"In theory, but even so, we could not match the numbers of one of the prominent System Lords, much less your numbers." Garshaw shook her head.

It wasn't about who was more powerful within the Alliance! Adora pressed her lips together so she wouldn't yell at the diplomats. They were here to form an alliance to defeat the Goa'uld, not to compete with each other.

Glimmer stood. "We cannot lose sight of the overall goal - the defeat of the System Lords and the liberation of their worlds and slaves. While we do have to take the future after the war into account when we discuss the proliferation of advanced technology, we first need to secure victory. Also, it should be obvious that Earth could easily, once the humans adapt Ancient technology, become a dominant power in the Galaxy by sheer weight of numbers."

That… wasn't quite how Adora would have put it. You couldn't effectively fight in a war if you were already worried about what your allies would do after the war.

"We will need time to adapt advanced technology," Sir Watson objected.

"And you aren't united," Adora pointed out. "Many of your countries do outnumber Etheria, many times in some cases, but most of them lack full access to advanced technology."

"Yes." Sir Watson nodded again.

“And you’ll probably fight each other before you would unite,” Catra commented.

Sir Watson frowned at her. “I would hope that humanity has grown beyond that.”

“Well, you might stick to a cold war like last time.” Catra shrugged.

Adora cleared her throat. “We’re here to form an alliance against the Goa’uld,” she reminded everyone. “Working together, we’re much stronger than alone since we complement each other.”

“The whole is greater than the sum of its parts,” Sir Watson agreed.

“We have a common enemy,” Garshaw said. “But we do need to take care not to sow the seeds for a new conflict while we fight this war.”

Adora nodded. They needed trust and cooperation. And she knew that fighting the Goa’uld could provide both - if they managed to form an alliance first.

Which they would. Adora would make sure. The others would see that it was the best course of action.

Of course, she added to herself with a glance at Sam and Jack as the debate continued, sometimes, even smart people don’t see what is obviously the best course of action. Stupid Air Fore rules! On the other hand, judging by what Adora had read up, the rules didn’t say officers couldn’t have a relationship with each other at all - just not within the same chain of command. But that would mean breaking up SG-1, which would be stupid as well.

The Air Force really needed to be more flexible, in Adora’s opinion. Not every rule needed to apply to everyone. Everyone was different, after all.

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Regulations

P34-353J, December 11th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and I think we have determined the key points that remain to be settled during the negotiations," Sir Watson finished with a smile as they gathered for the sendoff in the transporter room of the Tok'ra base.

For a man who had been negotiating with aliens for most of a day, the diplomat looked quite fit, in Samantha Carter's opinion. Of course, the Alliance wouldn't have sent the man if he couldn't stand a marathon negotiation session - and this was just the preliminary meeting to prepare the actual negotiations. They would only send their best diplomats.

And SG-1. Sam was very much aware that she wasn't just here because she was the best expert on Ancient technology on Earth but also because she was best friends with Entrapta and had good relations with Anise. Although, she amended her thoughts when she watched how the Tok'ra scientist smiled at the Colone, if Anise keeps bothering the Colonel, I might have to rethink my stance. The woman - either woman, Freya obviously shared that interest - shouldn't exploit the fact that the Colonel couldn't rebuff her as he obviously wanted due to diplomatic considerations.

"You should say something to them."

Sam froze for a moment, then turned to look at the speaker. Martouf. "Pardon?"

"Anise and Freya wouldn't go after someone who's involved with someone else," he told her in the same low voice as before. Too low to be picked up by anyone else in the room. Except for Catra - the woman's ears were twitching already.

Sam considered denying the implied statement, but that would have been lying. And she wouldn't stoop to that. "We aren't

involved," she said instead. "Regulations prohibit a relationship between officers in the same chain of command."

"But I think neither your nor his heart cares about regulations."

Sam bit back on the angry comeback - a good officer followed regulations. There were exceptions for saving the world, but not for personal… desires. But Martouf's expression was so… empathic fit it best, she decided. And she knew, thanks to the pang of guilt she felt, why he could feel that way - he and Lantash were both pining for someone they couldn't get, either.

Sam.

So she returned the smile in kind. "But we don't let our hearts rule us. There are good reasons for those regulations."

He inclined his head. "I don't doubt that, but I doubt that they are good enough to justify your and his unhappiness."

"We aren't unhappy." She had a great career. She had friends she trusted with her life. She could work with the most advanced technology on Earth and was making further advances. She had a lab in space and was best friends with a genius alien scientist. She could travel the galaxy. She wasn't unhappy.

But she didn't have… She pressed her lips together and pushed the small, nagging voice in the back of her mind away. Some things weren't meant to be.

But she could apply for a transfer. Away from SG-1. She would get it, Sam knew - as the leading scientist for Ancient technology, she could pick whatever posting she wanted. And that didn't even count her… influence with the leading power in the Alliance.

But that would… She was needed in SG-1. She couldn't leave. Not to mention what everyone would suspect about her reasons for leaving. And about her - and the Colonel.

Martouf inclined his head again, clearly not believing her. But he didn't push further. "I wish you happiness anyway."

Sam nodded in return. "Thank you. To you as well."

Then his lips shifted into a wry smile. "You should still talk to them, though." He glanced at the others in the room, gathering on the spot for the transporter. "And your friends, I think."

Sam caught Catra shaking her head at her. And elbowing Adora.

Yes, she thought with a sinking feeling, I need to talk with them. Before they tried to 'help' her. The last thing Sam - or anyone else - needed was a galactic superpower trying to meddle in her personal life.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 11th, 1998

"So…" Catra didn't grin when she approached Sam in her lab. Not much, at least - that would have been petty. And a bit cruel. Not that she had trouble with being either, but Sam was a friend, not an enemy.

Sam still gave her a flat stare that Mermista wouldn't have been able to top. "If you overheard my conversation with Martouf and Lantash, then you already know my response to whatever you are going to say."

Ah? Catra was tempted to claim she agreed with Sam's stance just to be contrarian, but that would have been petty. And stupid. "That's why I am starting with my response to your last statement," she said instead - with a grin.

Sam's eyes narrowed. "And what is your response?" she asked with a sigh.

“That your rules are stupid. You love him, he loves you, and rules that prevent two people in love from loving each other are stupid.” Rules, people, orders - whatever stood in the way of love was wrong.

Sam actually rolled her eyes. “It’s not as simple. Those rules were made for a very good reason.”

She hadn’t denied the other part of the statement, though. Catra sat down on the edge of Sam’s desk and picked up a screwdriver to fiddle with. People didn’t react to that as they reacted to sheathing and unsheathing her claws. “Don’t you have a saying about good intentions paving the road to hell?”

“Yes,” Sam admitted, and Catra’s grin widened. “But that’s not the case here. If relationships between an officer and one of their subordinates were allowed, it would be open to abuse.”

Catra shrugged. “The people who do that stuff generally don’t care about rules anyway.” At least, that had been her experience in the Horde. Not that the Horde had had such regulations.

Sam sighed again. “Some will be discouraged. But even if some would not care, the rules make it easier for the victim to seek help.”

“You don’t have such rules for your civilians, though. So, it can’t be that crucial.” Catra hadn’t heard that such stuff was common, anyway.

“Many private businesses and bureaucracies have rules to limit such relationships.”

“Really? Your movies and TV shows are wrong, then.” Catra snorted. She was aware of that. Mostly.

“Hollywood takes liberties with reality,” Sam said with a wry smile followed by a wince.

“But that’s not important,” Catra went on, cocking her head to the side as she crossed her legs and juggled the screwdriver. “Do you think Jack would do such a thing?”

“Of course not!” Sam snapped. “But that’s not the issue. Even if the majority of the people wouldn’t do a thing, there are always some who would if it were allowed, and the rule is meant to stop them.”

“And stops you and Jack. And probably others as well.” Which was stupid. “You should get an exception.”

Sam frowned deeply. “That’s not how it works. If exceptions are possible, then those who would abuse their power would abuse such exceptions.”

Catra shook her head. “Why don’t you stick to punishing those then, instead of everyone else?” It was easier to go after criminals than to turn everyone into criminals. Hell, even the Horde had taught you that punishing everyone for the faults of one or two was something you only did in special situations. Of course, in practice, things had been different, but still…

“Because the intent is to prevent such… problems. Not deal with them after someone got hurt.”

That still didn’t make much sense. “But you don’t have such rules for everyone. Just the military,” Catra pointed out.

“And many public and private organisations.”

Yes, she had mentioned that before. “You still should have some exceptions,” Catra insisted. “Too rigid rules are bad.” She knew that from personal experience. Damn Shadow Weaver.

Sam pressed her lips together. “Not everyone’s a princess who can make their own rules. And not every princess knows best.”

Catra didn’t wince at the barb even though it wasn’t… completely wrong. She shrugged. “Yeah, but you and Jack are an exception.”

No one deserved to be unhappy. Especially not her friends.

"No, we aren't. We're both officers in the United States Air Force. We have sworn an oath, and we will keep it." Sam pointedly turned to her computer, which Catra took as telling her that this conversation was over.

Well, one down, another to go. But she might have to change her approach now.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 12th, 1998

"Hi, Jack. Coffee?"

"Daniel?" Jack O'Neill generally liked every opportunity to put off his paperwork - well, the unnecessary paperwork; the kind of stuff someone once thought would be a good idea, ages ago, and which was kept on despite serving no purpose. Like writing a report for something he and everyone who had been there, as well as a few who hadn't, already had written a report about. But Daniel showing up so early in the morning, with the good coffee from his civilian-bought coffee maker? Without getting prompted by Jack? That raised some concerns. He still took the cup with a smile, of course.

"I thought you'd come in later today. Didn't you stay on past midnight to file your report?" Jack asked - as if he hadn't checked his subordinates' paperwork already; he would also have to tell Carter not to burn the midnight oil outside emergencies. Again.

His friend blushed. "Well, I like to write my reports when the memory's still fresh."

"Well, your memory's not going to stay fresh if you don't get enough sleep," Jack told him with a slight shake of his head.

Daniel pouted in return. “Who said that they could sleep when they’re dead?”

Jack chuckled. “That was in the middle of an emergency. Not after a boring diplomatic meeting to prepare the actual meeting.”

Daniel perked up instead of pouting some more, which raised more alarm bells in Jack’s head. “Well, it wasn’t that boring, was it?”

Jack shrugged. “People talking about talking. Of course, you’d find it interesting - you even find broken ceramic interesting.”

“Even so-called trash can tell us a lot about an ancient culture,” Daniel retorted. “But that’s a topic for another day.”

Like never, if Jack could help it. “Won’t see me arguing that.”

“Anyway.” Daniel took a deep breath. And another when Jack raised his eyebrows at him. “Glimmer asked me a few weird questions yesterday.”

“Yesterday?” Jack frowned. They had returned quite late through the Stargate, and Daniel had headed straight to his office, as far as Jack knew.

“Yes. She, ah, teleported into my office. Almost toppled a stack of Sumerian stone tablets.”

“I thought we agreed that she wouldn’t do that,” Jack said.

“Well, she didn’t know I had them, and so appeared a bit too close.”

“I mean the whole ‘teleporting into bases’ stuff,” Jack explained.

“Ah. She forgot, I think - it was late.” Daniel shrugged. “Anyway, she was asking a lot about marriage customs, relationships, and the cultural significance of rules and regulations.”

That was weird indeed. Glimmer had read up on that before, Jack knew - when the Etherians had negotiated with the various countries about gay marriage and other rights. But that was, as far as Jack knew, a done deal. And had been for a while.

"Mostly the latter," Daniel explained with the forced smile he usually had on his face when he wasn't sure about something but thought it was bad news.

So, what could… "Oh, damn!" Jack cursed, clenching his jaws.

"Yes. She was, well, not in those exact words, but she was asking about exemptions for certain rules about, ah, fraternisation?"

Jack closed his eyes to calm down and forced himself to unclench his teeth. Then he took a deep breath and sighed. They meant well. And they were stupid kids in some areas. Like this. "Don't tell me that magical space princesses are planning to meddle with my private life." At least Daniel had had the presence of mind to inform him.

"Well, they aren't meddling, at least I don't think they are - Glimmer seemed very aware of the cultural differences between Etherian and American military - but they're, ah, concerned." Daniel weakly smiled, Jack saw when he looked at his friend again.

"I said don't tell me."

"Technically, I told you they aren't meddling."

"But they're thinking about it." Jack sighed again and muttered another curse under his breath.

"They care about y… their friends," Daniel finished with a wince at Jack's glare. "They come from a completely different culture and social position, Jack. They don't really get why, ah, certain rules are the way they are. The idea that, ah, relationships between two adults could be prohibited by law goes against both their culture and their personal experience."

Oh, right. With the kind of messed-up personal history Adora and Catra had, they would completely misjudge the whole issue. The issue that Daniel wouldn't spell out if he knew what was good for him. "Great. Did you tell her not to meddle?"

"Well…" That wasn't the confirmation Jack wanted to hear. Not at all. "I explained the historical and cultural significance of the rules in question?" Daniel smiled weakly.

"To an absolute queen used to getting her whim."

"That's an unfair characterisation, Jack." And the pout was back. "Glimmer understands the importance of the rule of law - Bright Moon isn't an anarchy, and the queen can't just ignore the law on a whim. But their law generally is more, ah, flexible. It has more exemptions."

"You mean the princesses can play favourites." Jack pressed his lips together. Sure, there were mitigating circumstances, but on Earth, Catra and probably Scorpia and even Entrapta, but most definitely Hordak, would be behind bars for their actions in command of the Horde. Well, probably not Entrapta.

"They value their friends highly," Daniel sort of agreed. "And politics are personal for them, often based on personal relationships. Their culture reflects this." He shrugged with a smile. "It's actually not that different from the, ah, flexibility our own politics, especially international politics, has displayed in the past, just adapted to their own culture."

"Did you just compare meddling with my private life to propping up a dictatorship in the Cold War?" Jack asked with narrowed eyes.

Daniel blinked, mouth half-open. "Uh… I didn't mean… I mean, technically? I didn't mean that specific example, though. Just the leeway some people were shown for political reasons."

That still sounded like corruption to Jack. Whatever. "Well, next time you see them, ensure that they respect my… privacy." It

wasn’t as if he had a love life, anyway.

“Sure.” Daniel nodded a bit too quickly.

“And I’ll personally talk to them,” Jack added.

“That’s a good idea, yes.”

Jack sighed once more. His friend was a bit too obvious. “Soon, then.”

Daniel nodded again, looking relieved. Damn.

Jack nodded at him. “Thanks.” For telling him about this.

“Yeah, well…” Daniel shrugged, then nodded back and left.

Well, at least Jack had a good excuse not to finish his second report.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora frowned when Glimmer had finished the summary of her talk with Daniel over breakfast. “So we can’t help them?” She didn’t like that. Not at all. A couple kept apart by stupid rules…

“Well, he didn’t quite say that,” Glimmer said as she refilled her glass with fresh juice.

Adora refilled hers as well. Entrapta’s juicer was working very well, as long as you remembered to check if whoever had used it last had not forgotten to push the ‘clean&empty’ button. Certain flavours really didn’t mix well. Like anchovies and oranges, no matter what Catra said.

“But Sam was pretty angry when I talked to her,” Catra reminded her. “They take their rules seriously. Far too seriously.” She

stretched and swiped another slice of dark bread to top with smoked salmon.

Adora agreed. Catra might not take all rules seriously enough, but this was a very stupid rule.

"Daniel said it was a cultural thing," Glimmer said. "He said Earth, and especially the United States, was 'beholden to the rule of law'."

"And they have no princesses to step in and correct mistakes." Adora shook her head. "Isn't their president supposed to do that?"

"That would be favouritism, according to Sam. And they don't think it's a mistake," Catra said with a shrug. "Earth people don't really trust each other, so they want to make rules and laws that don't need trust."

Glimmer scoffed. "Oh, yes. Even the countries in the Alliance seem to expect the others to stab them in the back in the middle of the war."

"It's not that bad," Bow objected. "But they've had bad experiences with rulers and with allies. That colours their view. And Etheria has seen similar issues in the past. The Horde changed things since it was a threat to all of Etheria, so things are different in the Princess Alliance, but the other kingdoms haven't changed as much. Such actions were quite common once."

Adora nodded. She remembered the Princess Prom. So many princesses hadn't cared much or at all about the Horde threat. Not even after Catra and Scorpia had blown up Frosta's palace. Well, part of it. "But they wouldn't make such laws."

"Of course not. Limiting a princess's power like that would weaken their rule," Glimmer said.

"And we can't have that," Catra drawled with a smirk.

Glimmer shot her a glare. “Those who have the responsibility and duty also need to have the corresponding power.”

That sounded like a quote. Probably from Queen Angella. Adora pressed her lips together for a moment. “Anyway, how do we help our friends then?” There had to be a way to work with the system.

“That’s the question,” Catra said. “Sam was annoyed at me for telling her she should do something about it.”

“Uh…” Entrapta spoke up. “Are we sure that they love each other? Maybe they’re just friends.”

“Oh, yeah, they’ve got it bad for each other,” Catra said.

Glimmer nodded. “Definitely.”

“Yes.” Bow nodded as well.

“Yes,” Adora agreed with her friends. It was obvious.

“But why wouldn’t they want to be together if they loved each other?” Entrapta asked.

“Because they don’t want us to ‘play favourites’ or something,” Catra said. “They think that will weaken the whole system they have and open it to abuse by others.” She shrugged.

Adora frowned again. “If they have officers who would abuse that, they need to get rid of them.”

“They have a lot of officers.” Bow shook his head. “They have more soldiers than a lot of kingdoms on Etheria have people. And not enough princesses. Well, people with the power and prestige of princesses. Almost everyone has someone above them - or is limited in other ways.”

“The numbers are like the Horde,” Catra said. “I couldn’t check everything myself, and the Force Captains were, well… of mixed

quality. Couldn't trust all of them, of course, but as long as things worked out more or less, other stuff took priority."

"Yes, loyalty was a concern in the Horde," Hordak agreed. He was staring at Catra, who smirked back at him. "But I think harsh punishments for those who abuse their position would be better than preventive prohibitions."

"We can't really make them reform their whole system," Bow objected. "They have it for a reason."

"A stupid reason," Catra retorted.

"But intervening in another kingdom is not done lightly," Glimmer said. "Usually, you don't do that over a stupid law."

"But we can't let our friends be unhappy like that," Adora reminded them. We all know where that leads to, she thought with a glance at Catra.

"But they might not be happy if we meddle," Bow said.

"Not at first, at least," Catra added with a grin.

"Should we meddle?" Entrapta asked. "If they don't want us to…" She shrugged. "Sam isn't afraid to say what she wants, is she? She would have said something if she wanted help, right?"

"She might be too proud for that," Hordak pointed out. "Or she thinks the consequences of doing something aren't worth it."

"Yeah, that sounds like her," Catra agreed.

"Oh." Entrapta pouted. "Poor Sam."

"And poor Jack," Catra added. "So, we should…"

Darla announcing a call interrupted her. Adora quickly checked who was calling. Stargate Command? "Put them through," she told the ship.

Jack's face appeared on the smaller screen in the kitchen. "Good morning, everyone."

He was smiling, but he didn't look happy, Adora noticed when she returned the greeting. Too many teeth were showing.

"I think we need to talk about a few things," he went on. "In private. Face to face. So, any chance you could visit today?"

That sounded… ominous. Adora felt a little queasy. On the other hand, maybe this was an opportunity to talk things through with Jack? Honesty was the best policy, after all.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 12th, 1998

"So… How's the lab work going?"

Samantha Carter suppressed a sigh at Daniel's comment. Her friend's attempt to make conversation while avoiding the elephant in the room - or, to be precise, the Colonel missing in the mess hall - was very transparent.

And that meant he knew why the Colonel had suddenly left the Mountain for a visit to the Etherians in orbit - without anyone else from SG-1. Well, Sam had a suspicion about the reasons for that, but she needed confirmation. So she narrowed her eyes at him. "So spill, Daniel - why did Colonel O'Neill leave so urgently this morning?"

"Ah…" Daniel opened his mouth, then closed it again and pushed his glasses up his nose. "I, ah, don't know exactly, actually."

"But you have a reasonable suspicion," Sam pressed.

"Indeed," Teal'c surprisingly supported her.

"Ah… Well, it's really just a guess…"

"Daniel…" She raised her eyebrows at him with a sigh.

He caved. "I think he's gone to tell our friends not to, ah, meddle with his private life."

"Ah." Sam pressed her lips together. Just as she had thought. Her friends had bothered the Colonel as well with their nonsense.

"They mean well?" Daniel's tone and weak smile turned it into a question.

"It's none of their business," Sam spat. Then she glanced around. If someone overheard them, the rumour mill would go into overdrive. And the damage that would do…. "We'll continue this in my lab." That would assure their privacy.

"Ah, I still have a report to… Alright." Daniel forced another smile.

Teal'c merely rose without a word.

By the time they reached Sam's lab, she had calmed down. A little, at least. It was true that their friends meant well, but they didn't understand. Not even after she had explained things to Catra. She sighed as she sat down at her desk.

"The Etherians have a different view of, ah, the private life of soldiers," Daniel said, sitting down on one of the tables with non-critical parts.

Teal'c cocked his head to the side.

"I am aware of that," Sam said. "But we're on Earth. In the Air Force."

"They grew up in a very different culture," Daniel tried again. "And their personal experience also has an impact. Adora and Catra, well…" He shrugged. "You know their history."

Sam did. And that mess was completely different from… living in accordance with sensible rules and regulations. It wasn't as if an

abusive parental figure was manipulating Sam's life. Dad might not have been the best father possible, but he certainly cared for Sam and tried his best.

"So, it's only understandable that they, ah, would react to what looks, from their perspective, like a rule prohibiting relationships such as theirs, by attempting to fix what they would see as a great injustice."

"I am aware that they see our laws as a problem," Sam snapped. Her friend was dancing around the issue, which was annoying.

"I think they are primarily troubled by the Air Force regulations that prohibit two soldiers from forming a relationship," Teal'c commented. "Such as Colonel O'Neill and yourself."

Sam suppressed a gasp and stared at him. He was going there?

Teal'c weathered her glare with a slight tilting of his head and a small smile.

She clenched her jaw. Maybe dancing around the issue would have been better.

Daniel cleared his throat and went to refill his mug. Coward.

"My relationship with Colonel O'Neill is strictly professional," Sam very carefully said.

"Indeed. But it need not be." Teal'c took a sip from his own cup.

Sam took a deep breath, suppressing both the urge to yell at her friend - friends - and the feeling of longing. "What 'need not be' doesn't matter. We have those rules and regulations for a reason. A very good reason."

"Well, relationships between officers are only prohibited if they are within the same chain of command," Daniel pointed out.

As if Sam wasn't aware of that! But that would mean breaking up SG-1. And apart from the personal cost that would incur - Sam didn't trust anyone else as much as her team, and she would loathe seeing them fight without her - there was nobody else who could replace them. Not yet, at least. None were as qualified as Sam and Daniel in their fields. And Teal'c was… Teal'c. His knowledge of the Goa'uld was crucial, and he was the best fighter she knew. Not counting princesses. And the Colonel… Well, he would be promoted sooner or later.

But not today. Or tomorrow. And when the Colonel was promoted, he would likely move up to command Stargate Command. Or whatever formation SG-1 would be serving in at that point - Sam was aware that the odds of them staying in Stargate Command as the war began in earnest were low.

In any case, she would still be in his chain of command for the foreseeable future. She could apply for a transfer, but… Sam didn't want to become stuck in a lab. She was a soldier, not merely a scientist. Sometimes - quite often, actually - her skills were needed on the frontlines. She was needed there.

And she wouldn't sacrifice that for personal, selfish reasons.

No matter how much she wanted to.

"I'm not going to transfer out," she said, nodding firmly.

Teal'c nodded, and Daniel looked both relieved and disappointed.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

O'Neill was annoyed. And angry. Catra could tell the moment he stepped off the ramp of the shuttle in Darla's hangar. His smile showed his teeth, and if he had had the ears for it, they would have been flat against his head. She half-expected him to hiss, too, as he greeted them. "Hi, kids."

“Hi, Jack!” Adora beamed at him, but Catra’s lover was nervous. Her smile was just a tad too wide, and her tone just a bit too loud.

“Hi, Jack!” Catra waved. She wasn’t nervous. It wasn’t as if they had done anything to feel really guilty about. No war had been started, and no one had been killed. Just trying to help out two friends. Even if they didn’t want to get helped. Or especially if they didn’t want to get helped.

“The others are in the lounge. That should be private enough for… whatever you want to talk about.” Adora nodded twice and gestured towards the hangar door as if O’Neill hadn’t spent more than a month on the ship and knew exactly where everything was.

Catra sighed and shook her head as she followed the two.

“Hi, kids!” O’Neill repeated himself when they entered the lounge.

“Hi, Jack!” Bow smiled at him.

“Hello, Jack!” Glimmer nodded.

“Good morning, Colonel O’Neill,” Hordak said in a flat tone.

“Kids? I don’t think we qualify as kids according to the accepted definition, Jack.” Entrapta looked puzzled.

“For someone my age, you all look like kids.”

“Even Hordak? Since you’re actually younger than him, I think.” Entrapta frowned.

Catra grinned at the question - O’Neill looked momentarily taken aback.

But the man recovered quickly and sat down in one of the chairs to the side, facing the couch with Glimmer and Bow and the

armchair where Catra decided to sit on Adora's lap, leaving Entrapta and Hordak's couch to the side. As expected.

"So… I've heard you were looking into certain Air Force regulations," O'Neill said.

"Yes? I mean, yes," Adora replied with a nod.

"Regulations about the proper conduct of officers in the Air Force." O'Neill leaned forward with a frown.

"Regulations that state you and Sam can't get together." Catra flashed her teeth at him.

He narrowed his eyes at her for a moment. "And you are planning to do something about that," he went on in a flat voice.

"Yes?" Adora shifted a bit in the seat. Not enough to move Catra out of her lap, but enough to force her to adjust her own seat. "I mean, it's obvious that you two…"

"Stop," O'Neill interrupted her. Yes, he was angry now but controlled himself. Oops. "I don't know how things are done on Etheria, but on Earth, you respect your friends' privacy. And you don't start spreading rumours about them."

"Your TV shows disagree with that," Catra pointed out.

"That's TV." O'Neill glared at her. "It's not a role model - and not funny when it happens to you."

Catra wanted to disagree with that, but O'Neill was mad right now.

"But aren't you in love with Sam?" Adora asked.

The man closed his eyes for a moment and sighed. But he was still tense when he looked at them, Catra noticed. "That's not important. Not at all. You don't mess with your friends' - or anyone's - private life."

"Not even when they are, ah… 'showing self-destructive behaviour'?" Entrapta asked. "That would be an 'intervention' according to my data."

"We're not talking about drug abuse or drinking or whatever," O'Neill replied. "We're talking - entirely hypothetically - about two people not doing a thing that would break rules and regulations. And contrary to what kids might think, not acting on every *urge* isn't the end of the world."

Catra glared at him. Not acting on such 'urges' had almost caused the end of the world! Worlds, actually.

"We're talking about love, not urges," Adora objected.

"And if you don't want friends interfering with your love life," Glimmer added, "then why do you let rules interfere with your love life? That's basically the same thing."

O'Neill sighed again. "It's not the same thing."

"Why not?" Entrapta asked.

"I should have taken Daniel with me," Catra heard O'Neill mutter under his breath. "Look, those rules were created for a good reason. It's like… You know, it's like traffic rules."

"Traffic rules?" Glimmer cocked her head to the side.

"Do you mean trafficking?" Entrapta asked.

"No! Traffic. Cars on roads. On roads, you have a speed limit - the maximum speed you're allowed to go. That's because letting everyone drive at whatever speed they wanted to drive would mean a lot of people would drive too fast and endanger others. And even if you think you could drive faster without risking an accident, you don't do it. Because if you do it, others will do it as well - and they might not be able to safely handle their car at the same speed. And that means they'll crash. Probably into someone else."

"Ah." Entrapta nodded. "So, you serve as a role model for others by conforming to laws that shouldn't apply to you."

"But you have exceptions for that," Glimmer retorted. "The police are allowed to drive faster."

"In emergencies," O'Neill replied. "And this isn't an emergency."

"But we're talking about your… private life," Adora protested. "Not about cars."

"*My* private life, yes. If I need help, I'll ask for it."

Catra had her doubts about that.

"Look, I know you mean well, but messing with our rules like that will hurt a lot of people. I have seen lives ruined by people… getting involved with each other. Or abuse their power. We need those rules. And every exception would weaken them." O'Neill shook his head. "It's not worth it."

Catra doubted that. Love and happiness were worth it. Everyone deserved to be happy.

But it was O'Neill's life. And Sam's, though Sam hadn't wanted them to help either. So, it was, ultimately, up to them. Even though they were being stupid about it.

He looked at them. "Do you understand that?"

Catra was tempted to shrug, but everyone else was, reluctantly, nodding, so she did as well. But once they finally saw reason, Catra wouldn't let them forget this for a long, long while!

He sighed. "Ask Daniel about the reasons for those rules."

"I did," Glimmer said. "His explanation didn't sound very convincing."

“Well, ask him again.” Under his breath, Catra heard him add: “He deserves it.”

*****

Jack O’Neill felt a bit guilty about throwing Daniel under the bus. But this was something his friend should have handled when he had been talking with Glimmer. If Daniel had done his job, Jack wouldn’t have had to read a bunch of well-meaning magical princesses the riot act and wouldn’t have to look at half a dozen disappointed faces. Well, four. Hordak looked bored, and Entrapta was focusing on her portable super-computer. Or three - Catra didn’t look too disappointed.

Still, Jack felt guilty about that as well. “So, yeah, that was what I wanted to talk about.” He nodded, suddenly feeling awkward.

“Sorry,” Adora said. She looked far too sad for someone with their lover in their lap, Jack couldn’t help thinking.

Glimmer, though, frowned. “But with those rules, what about mixed formations or chains of command?”

“Ah… everyone follows their own rules, I think,” Jack replied - but he didn’t think it would be so easy.

“Our rules say a princess can adjust such rules,” Glimmer pointed out with a wry expression. “And our people are used to that.”

Just forbidding fraternisation wouldn’t work - Jack knew soldiers; fraternisation would happen anyway, but under strict rules, people tended to be more discreet. If they expected a princess to bail them out…

“You can’t really expect us to forbid our people from following their hearts,” Glimmer added. “Or not help them if they ask us to.”

Yeah, Jack knew better than to expect the same people who picked their allies according to how tolerant they were of gay love to play along with a strict non-fraternisation policy. “Well, that

seems like a question that should be handled by the brass," he said. He absolutely didn't feel guilty about throwing them to the wolves - handling that was their job, after all. And Hammond was good at it.

And now everyone was frowning at him. Damn.

"Now that you said your piece, it's suddenly none of your business any more?" Catra shook her head.

And Adora nodded. "Yes. You obviously thought about this."

"We would like your opinion on this." Glimmer wasn't smiling, but Jack was sure she wanted to.

He sighed. "Well, we have different cultures - military cultures. We don't really like the idea of staff officers playing favourites." He had explained that, hadn't he?

"Yes. But our people expect us to take care of them," Glimmer insisted. "Even - or especially - when visiting another kingdom."

And there went Jack's 'when in Rome, do as the Romans do' idea. Not that that would have worked well once the Etherians found out how the United States insisted on not subjecting their soldiers to foreign laws.

"We could just treat any formation with Etherians as an Etherian formation," Bow suggested.

"Yes!" Adora nodded. "That would mean they wouldn't be subject to your regulations! And they would be free to have relationships with soldiers in other formations since those wouldn't be in the same chain of command!"

That sounded… well, if no Etherians served with Americans, that would work. Sort of. The brass wouldn't be happy, of course. And Jack knew, though some politicians might not, that soldiers would fraternise anyway. And since this would, technically, not break any

rules… He shrugged. “Well, I’m no lawyer or politician, but it might work. Don’t quote me on that, though,” he quickly added.

The last thing he wanted was to be dragged into a discussion of this proposal with the brass. Handling politics like this wasn’t his job - he was only here to ensure that his completely hypothetical relationship - it wasn’t as if he even knew what Carter thought about that - wouldn’t be meddled with by magical space princesses.

And that was a job well done, if Jack did say so himself.

*****

Mistakes

Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 12th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Adora sighed once Jack had left with the shuttle. "We made a mistake."

"We underestimated how attached they are to their stupid rules," Catra said. "That's all. If they want us, we can solve their problem for them."

Adora frowned at her. "You sound as if you expect them to come back and ask us for help."

"Of course I do," Catra said. "If they could solve their problem themselves, they would have done so already." She snorted and stretched her arms over her head. "Although we could have saved some time and effort and just asked beforehand. Or we could have been a bit sneakier so they wouldn't have noticed."

"But then we would have done it against their wishes," Entrapta pointed out.

"They obviously don't know what they want," Catra retorted. "They think rules are more important than their love." She shook her head.

"Well, Jack made a good case for why they don't want to get an exemption from that rule," Bow said. "I mean… he explained his reasons," he added when Glimmer frowned at him. "And we need to keep in mind that they come from another world. They do things differently on Earth."

Adora nodded, though she wasn't sure if she agreed completely. As long as you didn't count the bigotry, love and relationships were basically the same on Earth and on Etheria, that much she knew. And not just from watching television. Well, mostly from television, but she had seen couples as well.

“And they’re wrong,” Catra insisted. “Sticking to rules against common sense is a recipe for disaster.”

Adora nodded again. She agreed with that. Well, with the rules comment.

“The question is,” Bow spoke up again, “do their rules go against common sense?” Both Catra and Glimmer frowned at him, but he shrugged. “We’re talking about a country with five to six times the population of Etheria. I am not sure if such a country could be run like one of our kingdoms.”

That was a good point. The instructors in cadet training had told them that what worked for a squad wouldn’t work for a company or battalion.

“They still need flexible rules,” Glimmer said. “No rule can cover everything and remain fair.”

“Yes, exactly!” Catra agreed emphatically - before blinking and frowning - and looking away from Glimmer, who was frowning as well.

Adora suppressed a chuckle at her friends’ antics. She quickly grew serious again, though - this was a serious problem. “But they have experience with their way of doing things. We don’t.”

“So? The Horde had a lot of experience doing stuff the Horde way, and they were wrong,” Catra said.

“Adapting an organisation for clones mindlessly following Horde Prime to incorporate soldiers that could not share the same thoughts is a challenge,” Hordak said. He wasn’t looking at Catra, but everyone knew he was responding to her criticism.

“Yes!” Entrapta chimed in. “We’re still fiddling with the new Horde organisation. Although the differences between Second and Third Fleet also make this a challenge.”

"So? As long as they follow Adora's orders, it works." Catra shrugged again. "Better than the rest of the Alliance."

"The circumstances are quite different," Glimmer objected. "Every member of the Alliance has their own military led by their princess. It took a long time to earn their trust."

And Adora still wasn't sure she deserved that trust. She was She-Ra, but she had grown up in the Horde, not as a princess.

Although, since now they had so many countries from Earth in the Alliance, maybe that wasn't a bad thing. It was clear that they had to adapt their rules as well. And they needed to do so before they started the actual fighting side by side with the Earth soldiers.

But rules that required you to abandon your love and happiness were simply wrong. No matter what Jack said about that, there had to be a way to solve this so Sam and he could be happy together.

They just had to find it.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 12th, 1998

Thanks to the latest experimental version of the magic scanner alerting her and her computer's connection to the Mountain's security system, Samantha Carter watched the shuttle touch down on the landing pad outside the Mountain from her lab. The Colonel had returned.

She made a note about possible improvements for the scanner's interface - especially a better method to mesh the scanner's data with camera footage - and then headed towards the Colonel's office. If he was returning from an official mission or even an errand, he'd usually report to General Hammond right away. So, if he wasn't headed to the General's office but his own…

And there he was. “Colonel,” she greeted him.

“Carter.” A half-wince appeared on his face before it settled into a polite smile. “What’s up?”

Sam had an excuse ready. Multiple excuses, actually. She could report on her work with the scanner. Ask about the performance of the shuttle - she had been involved, if only in an accessory capacity, with its design. Give him an update about her work for the relocation of Stargate Command. All true and, therefore, good excuses for going to see the Colonel.

She didn’t feel like using any of them. Instead, she followed him into his office and asked: “Did you succeed in convincing the Etherians to respect Air Force regulations, sir?”

His eyes widened slightly before his polite smile turned into that familiar wry grin. “I hope so,” he said. “They apologised for trying to… meddle.” With a sigh, he added: “Though I don’t know if it took - they wanted to discuss regulations for mixed formations after my talk.”

“Ah.” Sam nodded slowly. That was… better than she had expected but not as good as she had hoped.

He shrugged. “You know the kids - they mean well. But that doesn’t excuse their meddling. This is Earth, not Etheria.”

“Yes, sir.” Sam nodded again. “They are from a different culture, but they need to respect our own.”

“Yep.” After a moment, he added: “It doesn’t help that they’ve been watching TV, of course.”

Sam pressed her lips together. Friends meddling with their friends’ love lives was a common plot in many TV shows - and often, far too often, in her opinion, that behaviour was presented not nearly negatively enough. “Hollywood has a lot to answer, sir.” She had to struggle a little to keep herself from grimacing when she

realised what she was doing - thinking about this as affecting her *love life* was a dangerous line of thought.

"Definitely." He snorted. "But I don't think they get the different culture bit. I can't help thinking that they apologised because I told them in person to stop and not because they realised their way of doing things won't work on Earth."

And the Colonel wouldn't have asked them to stop in person and in private unless he, too, felt… She shut down that line of thought. She really didn't want to go there. "To be fair, sir," she said before the short pause became awkward, "They didn't get the best impression of our customs." Entrapta, in her usual inadvertently blunt but honest manner, certainly had not left any doubt about that. "And since we actually changed the Constitution to meet their standards for the Alliance, they wouldn't have felt any need to question their own values."

He grimaced. "Yep, that certainly didn't help either." After a moment, he shrugged - a bit forced, in her opinion; she knew him well enough to tell. "Well, it's in the hand of the brass; I told our friends that they needed to discuss regulations for mixed formations with the people paid to worry about those things."

Sam frowned. "What do they consider mixed formations, sir?"

Another grimace. "I would say soldiers from Etheria and Earth in the same unit, but I didn't actually ask how far they would break that down - or how far they would scale that up."

Sam nodded. She could see the problem. "If they consider any unit under the command of an Etherian a mixed formation, then that would have unfortunate implications." Adora was the designated Supreme Commander of the Alliance, after all.

"Yep. But I don't think they're that sneaky. They wouldn't try to argue that. Not Adora, at least."

"But Catra might support that interpretation," Sam pointed out. She could easily see that.

“Yeah. But she’s just one of them. And not a princess. Technically.” The Colonel sounded as if he was trying to convince himself.

But Catra was Adora’s lover - and amongst the Etherians, she, together with Hordak, had the most experience in commanding forces similar to Earth’s armies. “You might need to talk to Adora about that, sir,” Sam said.

Sighing, he nodded. “I guess so. I really hoped I could dodge that bullet,” he added with a wry grin.

She matched his smile. “I trust you, sir.”

“Thanks.” His smile shifted a little, and, for a moment, Sam didn’t know what to say now.

The moment grew awkward quickly. They were still standing in the middle of his office - too close, Sam belatedly realised. Far too close for comfort. If she reached out, she could touch his shoulder. Or he hers.

Stiffly she nodded once more. “Well, it seems you have this handled, sir.”

“Ah, yes, Captain,” he replied with a slightly jerky nod.

“Good. If that’s all…?” she said before she caught herself. Hell, this was suddenly awkward.

“Ah, no, that’s it.”

“Then I will return to work, sir.”

“You do that, Captain.”

She turned as if she were on a parade ground and marched out of his office.

Then she sighed. She felt as if she had dodged a bullet herself - and like she had missed a shot.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 13th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...and negotiations with the Tok'ra continue in the face of persistent protests against making a deal with the Goa'uld…"

"...you have to understand, Bob, that the Tok'ra aren't Goa'uld. Well, biologically, they are, but the differences between them and the Tok'ra are as significant as the differences between the Nazis and the Allies in World War II.

Well, Bill, our allies in World War II weren't exactly nice either, were they? Two colonial empires that were oppressing half the globe and a bloody dictatorship that would go on to subjugate half of Europe. Who's to say we won't end up in a Cold War with those people? We need to keep that in mind when dealing with those snakes, and we need to ask ourselves if we really need them as allies.

We're currently allied with a planet ruled by princesses, Bob. Absolute monarchs. Do you expect them to turn against us as well?

I'm just saying we need to be prepared. The United States cannot depend on anyone else for its security."

Sitting in Adora's seat on the bridge, Catra rolled her eyes at the screen. They went from discussing the Tok'ra to discussing Etheria - and she hadn't missed the copout at the end. "Those people really expect everyone to betray them," she muttered.

Probably because they were ready to betray everyone as soon as it was convenient for them. Or if they thought it was convenient for them. She knew from experience that misjudging the long-term consequences - or dismissing them - was a grave mistake when making plans. But if there was one thing she had learned after Adora had saved her - apart from how stupid Catra had been

for not realising they were in love, of course - it was that you had to trust to be trusted.

But she also knew that trusting the wrong people was a potentially fatal mistake. “Shadow Weaver,” she muttered as she switched the channel.

“...and despite the Secretary General of NATO’s repeated assurances that the Alliance had no intention to attack or threaten any other country on Earth and the building up of forces, as well as the incorporation of advanced alien technology in its arsenal, was purely aimed to counter the threat posed by the Goa’uld Empire, many nations have voiced their concerns and fears about the shifting balance of power, citing historical precedents, and a proposal in the United Nations is gathering support…”

“...and it pains me to see that even so close to the most holy day of the year, when we should be preparing to celebrate the birth of our Saviour, the world is not only ready to plunge into war but preparing to join forces with evil. Haven’t we learned anything from history? Doesn’t the Holy Bible tell us what happens if you trust snakes? We need to…”

Catra scowled - why did the news keep giving those religious nutcases any screen time? She switched the screen to a feed from the bot network surrounding Earth and spreading into the Solar System and leaned back. What a way to start the day.

“What’s wrong?”

Catra turned her head. Adora had just entered the bridge, carrying two steaming mugs. Chocolate, Catra’s nose told her. “Just commenting on the stuff the news cover,” she said as she slid out of the seat. “Come, sit down!”

“You just want to sit in my lap,” Adora replied as she handed over Catra’s mug. But she sat down anyway, and Catra did slip in her lap, then took a sip. “Mhh.”

They sat in silence for a little while, watching the Earth through the windows - and the various other planets on the screen - until a ping announced a message. Catra was tempted to ignore it, but Adora being Adora, reached out and put it on the screen, replacing Mars.

It was their mail report from - whatever was considered important enough to pass on to them instead of being handled by a bot. While Adora grabbed a pad and started to go over the letters - scanned, of course - that were mostly calls for help, Catra picked up her own and checked the rest of the report.

Oh. "Speaking of religious nutcases…" she said, shaking her head.

"I thought we didn't get told about hatemail anymore," Adora commented.

"We don't. This is the summary of what the security bots have found. It looks like the bombs are getting more sophisticated, and one bigot upgraded to poison." Catra snorted. "All that effort, and they didn't bother to check whether we actually receive the mail in person!" Of course, the kind of scum sending such stuff probably considered everyone working with them an acceptable target. Well, the police were on the case. And Entrapta's scanners could detect any such threats.

Still, with Earth starting production of advanced weapons, the threats would grow more sophisticated. How soon until a nutcase tried to hijack a shuttle? How soon until a nutcase succeeded and tried to ram Darla?

Yeah, extending trust to people also had drawbacks. Catra would have to hope that Entrapta kept ahead of their enemies with her technology.

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P34-353J, December 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill wasn't a diplomat. Sure, he had talked his way out of trouble before, a couple of times, maybe more often than he had talked his way into trouble, but he was a soldier, not a negotiator. And he was a field officer, not a flag rank. Sure, he was a colonel, one rank below a one-star, and it wasn't as if he knew nothing about strategy, but his main experience was on the tactical level. So, it should have been obvious that he wasn't the best choice when it came to picking officers for the alliance negotiations with the Tok'ra.

But, apparently, his experience with aliens was 'invaluable', and his advice 'crucial', and so he had been attached to the delegation meeting the snakes. That was the official reason, at least - unofficially, Jack was sure that they had sent him along because he was friends with the Etherians and had done his part to defuse the bomb that would have blown up the High Council of the snakes, and the brass, as well as the government, counted on that to influence the negotiations. General Pecks, the ranking US officer of the delegation, certainly had hinted at that in the briefing.

At least the ground pounder hadn't told Jack to lie back and think of America, but Jack couldn't help thinking that the interest Anise was showing in his genes was also a factor. It wasn't as if anyone had needed his advice so far.

"...and while we agree that there are clear advantages to a unified command, there are also disadvantages. If the supreme commander makes a mistake, the consequences could be fatal. A more diverse force can survive such mistakes and keep fighting." Per'sus smiled as brightly as when the negotiations had begun hours ago.

"While that is, technically, true, it is a stance based on fighting a shadow war - a war fought by spies and saboteurs, where being discovered is lethal. Our war against the Goa'uld will be fought by armies and fleets, not small teams of saboteurs. And in such a war, defeat in detail is the bigger threat - and a lack of coordination will result in higher casualties than we'd suffer with a

unified command that can have all forces support each other and follow a coordinated strategy." Glimmer's smile wasn't quite as bright - and not just because she didn't have the superhuman stamina of a snake, in Jack's opinion. She wasn't happy with the proceedings so far.

Well, he wasn't happy either. Even a cadet would be aware that you need a unified command to effectively fight a war. Well, maybe not a first year, but a second year for sure. But the snakes were still stuck in their spy mindset - and no matter how often Daniel claimed that it was perfectly logical given their history, it was holding things up.

Of course, Jack could understand not wanting to fight under the command of a foreigner - or, worse, a Navy puke - but if the US had to accept that, the Tok'ra could do so as well. Even more so since, apparently, the Tok'ra had no issues with Adora's age - though that was probably because they considered her an Ancient.

"And you will have a say as well about the strategic decisions," Adora added - for the third time, by Jack's count. "You won't have to obey blindly. Decisions will be debated, and advice will be listened to."

"But ultimately, it will be your decision," Garshaw said. "Yours and your closest advisors'."

Adora frowned, but Glimmer narrowed her eyes and spoke before she could reply. "I don't like this implication. That's not how we do things. Everyone gets a say."

"But some voices weigh more than others," Garshaw retorted. "That's only natural."

"That depends on their arguments and experience," Adora said.

"Yes," Glimmer agreed. "And we will be relying on your experience when it comes to the Goa'uld. You can count on that."

“But we won’t be blindly following your advice either,” Catra cut in, not bothering to straighten in her seat. Jack almost expected her to put her feet up on the table. “Also, you don’t have to worry about getting ordered to suicide-charge Jaffa lines anyway - we know that that’s not your strength.”

“And who will you order into suicide charges?” Hen’ru asked.

“Bots,” Catra shot back. “Dumb bots.”

Adora nodded.

“And what if there are no bots available?” Hen’ru didn’t relent.

The guy probably had spent too much time amongst snakes - evil snakes, in Jack’s opinion. Well, time to justify why he was here. “Whoever’s available in that case,” he said. “You can’t really plan that. It’s a difficult decision, yes, but you have to trust your commander to use their best judgement.” It all came down to that - trust.

Adora nodded. “Yes. We need a unified command, or the alliance can’t really work. But we won’t abuse that power. You have my word.”

The Tok’ra exchanged glances. For a moment, Jack hoped they would realise that Adora was honest to a fault.

“Yes, of course, but we do have concerns,” Per’sus said. “Even with the best intentions, a commander can make a mistake if they rely on faulty intel.”

“Well, that’s what happens in war.” Catra shrugged. “And when it happens, you take your losses and keep going. You can’t tell me you didn’t have screw-ups that killed your people.”

Jack suppressed a grin. They certainly couldn’t - not after a spy almost blew them up.

The Tok’ra exchanged more glances. “Yes, of course,” Garshaw said with a polite smile. “However, while we agree in principle to a unified command, crucial details still need to be settled.”

Jack sighed. This was going to take a while. At least, it looked as if the Tok’ra accepted Supreme Commander Adora.

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After another hour, they were still not done with all the crucial details. The Tok’ra might be attempting to exhaust them into agreeing, in Jack’s opinion. Although they might have underestimated how stubborn Glimmer was - and Sir Watson, for all his politeness and British-ness, kept insisting on changes to the Tok’ra proposals that even Jack wouldn’t have worried about.

But they finally could take a break - even though, Jack suspected, for Glimmer and the other leaders, it merely meant that they would negotiate more informally over food. But at least they got to eat - just sitting and listening, in case his advice was actually needed, had left him quite hungry.

He looked around for his friends, but Daniel had made a beeline for Per’sus as soon as the break had started, and Carter was already talking in a corner with Entrapta and Anise. Maybe he should go over there and remind Carter to eat? No, that would be patronising. Besides, if she was occupying Anise, then the least he could do was honouring her sacrifice.

The buffet was stacked as before, so Jack could pick what he already knew was good and leave the rest for the diplomats and Peck. If he felt like it, he might even point out the fried brain snacks before everyone had tried them. Now, where did the snakes place the noodles? The fish dishes were easy to find; Catra had headed straight to that part of the buffet, but the noodles were…

“Are you looking for the Ka’met, Colonel O’Neill?”

Jack turned and smiled at Anise. “Ka’met?” he asked while he glanced around - he couldn’t spot Carter, but Entrpata was at the other side of the buffet.

“Fried noodles, I think, you called them before.”

Had she ordered them hidden to have an opener? No, Jack didn’t think Anise was the type to be so subtle - the snake had no problem being blunt. On the other hand, she had apparently noticed last time that he had liked that dish. Did he have an alien stalker? “Yes, actually,” he said.

“The grain-based food is over here.” She pointed at a row of owls with various mashed stuff in it - it looked like a mashed potatoes display at a barbecue after the kids got the food colouring set.

“Thank you.” He stepped over there and spotted the noddles - cleverly hidden between green and bright orange mush that no red-blooded American man would want to look at.

“It’s been quite a tiring negotiation session so far.” Anise had followed him and was scooping out two helpings of the green mush.

Jack shrugged. “That’s par for the course for diplomatic meetings. People can never simply agree to something.” Not unless you asked them at gunpoint, and some of the diplomats he had seen today might object out of principle even then.

“It’s quite vexing when people do not agree to the logical solution,” she seemed to agree.

“I bet our diplomats say the same,” Jack retorted.

“I was talking about both sets of negotiators.” She tilted her head towards him. “The High Council is, unfortunately, understaffed with scientists.”

Jack snorted. “Well, if scientists were negotiating, I bet they would decide everything by experimenting.”

"Of course. That would be the rational solution." Anise nodded with a smile, and Jack wondered if he had to work on his sarcasm.

He started eating the noodles - Or Ka'met, whatever - and shrugged again.

"Anyway, I am happy that you are part of the Alliance delegation," Anise went on. "Since until the alliance has been formally sealed, travelling to Earth is restricted, I was hoping to meet you here."

And Jack was pretty sure why the snake wanted to meet him. "I think security precautions will still put some limits on travel to Earth." No one wanted to grant the snakes the freedom to travel unrestrictedly. Hell, the Etherians only got that because they had a fleet of spaceships with big honking guns and the tech everyone wanted.

"Well, limiting travel to the countries in the Alliance would be a rational compromise, I believe," Anise said.

"Maybe," Jack said as noncommittally as he could. Oh, Carter had just entered - and was headed straight towards him and Anise.

And he didn't think she was frowning as deeply as she did because she was hungry. Or that the frown was purely aimed at Anise.

Great.

*****

"Oh! Looks like Sam's about to stake her claim! Hah, so much for 'there's nothing between us'!"

Adora suppressed a wince at Catra's gleeful tone. Sam was their friend; they should respect her wishes. And Jack's. Even though she agreed with Catra - the two were obviously in love - that didn't mean they should be so eager to see their friends proven wrong. That was just… petty.

But Catra was correct - Sam was frowning at Anise and Jack. Which was a little unfair since, as far as Adora could tell, Jack hadn't done anything to encourage Anise and Freya. On the other hand, maybe Sam thought that he should have done something to discourage them.

"Do you think she'll hit them?" Catra asked - still sounding more amused than concerned.

Adora shook her head as she kept watching the scene; they were both at the buffet, where Catra was waiting for fresh fish dishes, so it wasn't rude. "She's got too much self-control," Adora said. They wouldn't have to fear a diplomatic incident.

"Oh, yes - if she had less self-control, she would have jumped at our offer. Or jumped his bones," Catra agreed.

Adora pressed her lips together. She shouldn't indulge, but… "What are they saying?" she whispered.

"Nothing interesting," Catra replied. "She's just asking Anise some technical stuff."

But Sam had been scowling openly while she was approaching the others; Adora had seen that clearly. And Jack was, well, his smile was strained, and he looked like he was trying not to wince. Anise, though, looked puzzled. But why…

"Supreme Commander?"

Oh. Malinor/Kalet had approached them. And Adora hadn't even noticed. Well, Catra must have missed it as well. "Yes?" Adora cocked her head slightly to the side and smiled as if she hadn't been staring at her friends.

"I was wondering about your plans for returning magic to the Galaxy," the Tok'ra councillor said. "Do you expect that this will facilitate rebellions on the planets held by the Goa'uld?"

Hadn’t Glimmer covered that already during their talks? But pointing that out would be rude - they were here to formalise an alliance, after all. So, Adora shook her head. “That’s unlikely. Magic - the kind sorceresses do - requires training. Years of training.” And as far as they knew, the Goa’uld had taken great pains to eliminate any knowledge about magic amongst their slaves.

“But that’s not the only kind of magic, is it?” Malinor leaned forward a little. He was holding an empty plate, but he didn’t seem to be interested in getting more food.

“Yes, there’re also magical talents that people are born with,” Adora told him.

“Some people,” Catra interjected between two bites from a large fried fish she had managed to grab from the buffet as soon as it was restocked. “Princesses. And they’re limited to Etheria.”

Adora nodded. That was true, as far as they knew at least.

“And Ancients, right?” Malinor smiled.

Right. *That* again. “She-Ra’s a special case,” Adora told him. She didn’t know for certain why she had become She-Ra. She had found the sword the First Ones had made to control Etheria’s magic, but She-Ra had existed before the First Ones had arrived. Her friends claimed Etheria’s magic had chosen her, that this was proof that it wasn’t the sword the First Ones had created that made her She-Ra, but Adora just didn’t know. And, knowing what the First Ones had been preparing Etheria for, she wasn’t sure she wanted to know.

Malinor nodded. “But as every scientist knows: If something was done once, it can be done again. Magitech can be used by anyone. Sooner or later, the Goa’uld will use magic as well - sooner rather than later, I fear, since they remember the time before magic disappeared.”

“They can’t activate a planet’s magic, though,” Adora pointed out. Only she could. “That will limit their options.”

“But you will activate magic on planets that you invade, won’t you?”

Of course - how else could the princesses use their magic? “Yes.”

“And the Goa’uld already can use magitech - what they have left, at least,” Catra said after finishing her fish.

“Some might be locked to Ancients and their descendants, they often limited their technology like that,” Malinor said.

“Then they just have to take over such a host.” Catra shrugged. “It’s something that will probably happen anyway. At least, they can’t use magic that way.”

“Yes. But have you considered the threat of the Goa’uld using indoctrinated slaves to do magic? It might take a long time to conquer a planet.”

Adora clenched her jaw. People raised from birth to unquestioningly serve the Goa’uld - that sounded very familiar.

Catra shrugged again. “They won’t be very effective.”

“Not at the start. But the longer they have, the more effective they’ll become.”

“Then we’ll ensure that they won’t have enough time,” Adora said. “And the longer we have, the better we’ll be prepared.”

“Which brings us to another question: Did you consider waiting a bit longer with the overt parts of the war so we’ll be better prepared?”

“That again!” Catra sighed. “We can’t let them have the initiative - they will strike at Earth again, sooner or later. Better to hit them first and make them react to us.”

"And we can't just let them keep oppressing people," Adora added with a frown. "We've gone over that before."

"Of course, but we didn't touch on how magic would affect that question. So…"

Adora grabbed a fish from Catra's plate and bit into it so she wouldn't grind her teeth. This was as bad as the negotiations on Earth.

*****

"And yes, I think that would work out well - provided we can harden the power supply to withstand the drain."

I shouldn't have done this, Samantha Carter thought. Intervening had been a mistake. I should have just ignored Anise hitting on the Colonel.

Yes, that would have been the best choice of action - it wasn't as if he was interested in starting a relationship with either Anise or Freya. Sam was sure of this - the Colonel's many comments about the Goa'uld left no doubt about how he felt about the 'snakes'.

But when she had spotted Anise making a move, Sam hadn't been able to simply ignore it. Instead, she had made a completely transparent attempt to derail whatever discussion Anise and the Colonel had had going by talking about their shared projects. Way to go, Sam, she told herself.

"Yes! I think we can solve that by doubling the powerlines - and adding more redundancy on the power supply side," Entrapta said.

That it had worked was no small consolation, though - Anise had stopped flirting with the Colonel. Or what the Tok'ra scientist considered flirting.

"Well, I see you've got the tech-talk going, so…" The Colonel smiled. "...I'll go check if someone needs a tactic-talk. Or a

hockey-talk. Or maybe I'll see if Catra wants to discuss the Simpsons' new catgirl character."

And with a nod, he left before anyone could say anything, leaving Sam wondering what he thought about her lapse.

"Oh. I think we've been rude, right?" Entrapta said, cocking her head while her hair continued to hold two plates, a glass and a computer. "Since Jack's not a scientist or involved in our projects - at least, I don't think he's involved in granting the funding, is he? Anyway, so he probably wasn't very interested in our project. And talking about something not everyone present is interested in is being rude." She nodded twice. "We might have to apologise, I think."

"I started it; I'll talk to him later," Sam said. "It was my fault, not yours." And it would allow her to sound out the Colonel without, well, being obvious about it. More obvious.

"OK. But we all bored him, right?"

"Only after I started it," Sam repeated herself. "Don't worry, if the Colonel's blaming anyone, it won't be you."

"Oh. But… didn't you know it was rude? Or were you impatient? I know it's hard to wait sometimes, but we're still in the planning phase."

Ah. Sam suppressed a wince. How to explain her actions without making her look foolish or lying to Entrapta? Maybe…

"Are you interested in Colonel O'Neill, Sam?"

Sam stiffened at Anise's question. "Regulations prohibit relationships between an officer and their subordinate," she replied almost reflexively before pressing her lips together. That wasn't a question you asked!

"That doesn't answer my question," Anise said, frowning. Then she cocked her head and grew still, somehow suddenly looking

very alien. “Ah. Maybe it does.” She nodded.

Freya must have commented, Sam realised. Anise’s host saw what Anise was seeing. And Freya was interested in the Colonel as well, Sam reminded herself.

“It does?” Entrapta blinked. “Ah, I see.” She nodded. “Yes, all my friends think so as well.”

Sam really didn’t like the smile on Anise’s face, but it was quickly replaced by a sigh. “You should have stated your interest clearly, Sam,” she - no, that was Freya’s voice - said.

Was she insinuating that Sam had missed her shot? Sam could think of a few things that wouldn’t miss Anise or Freya… She pushed the irrational bout of overrating aggression away. “As I said, regulations prohibit any relationship between an officer and their subordinate.”

“Yes!” Entrapta chimed in. “We wanted to help them abolish that regulation - or get an exception - but that would be bad. Apparently.”

Sam refrained from glaring at her friend. Unlike the other alien participating in this discussion, Entrapta didn’t know any better and didn’t mean anything by her comment. Nothing she didn’t say, at least.

“But you are interested.” Anise nodded. “If there were no regulations…”

“Those regulations were made for very good reasons,” Sam interrupted her through clenched teeth. “And that’s not going to change.”

“And yet, you don’t plan on finding another partner, do you?” Anise slowly nodded as if she already knew the answer.

“I am very busy with crucial work - as you already know,” Sam told her. “Too busy to look for a relationship.”

“Well, you could pick a lab buddy! That’s how Hordak and I got together!” Entrapta beamed at her.

Her friend didn’t know any better, Sam reminded herself again.

“What about Iwan?” Entrapta went on. “He’s funny and nice, isn’t he?”

“I am not interested in Dr Georgovich that way,” Sam said. Not to mention that their cooperation would only last as long as Sam was assigned to Stargate Command.

“Ah.” Anise’s smile shifted into an expression of pity. “You are in a bind, then. You’re unwilling to defy regulations - and you are in love with Colonel O’Neill. Is he aware of that?” Before Sam could think of an answer that wouldn’t lead to a diplomatic incident, she nodded. “He would be - and he would return your interest. Otherwise, you would have moved on, I am sure.”

Yes, of course - Sam wouldn’t pine after a man who wasn’t interested. She didn’t say that out loud. And she was aware that the difference between pining after someone who wasn’t interested and someone who wasn’t allowed to have a relationship with her was mostly a technicality.

She didn’t say that either, of course. Instead, she said: “Emotions are not very rational.”

“Ah, yes.” Entrapta nodded as if Sam had something insightful.

Sam was looking at Anise, anyway.

The Tok’ra nodded as well - with a smile. “This simplifies things.”

“What?” Sam blurted out.

“Yes. While regrettable from a personal point of view - Colonel O’Neill is a very impressive man, and both Freya and I think he would be a great partner - now that this has been revealed, we can stop trying to entice him into a relationship and focus on

convincing him to donate his genetic material. That should be much easier!” Anise beamed.

Sam stared. Were they serious?

And Catra started laughing behind them.

*****

Misunderstandings

P34-353J, December 14th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Catra met Sam's glare with another chuckle. "See, that happens if you aren't honest about your feelings," she said - even though she was too far away for Sam to hear her words.

"Catra!" Adora hissed next to her.

"Oh, come on!" Catra pouted at her lover. "It's funny!"

"It's not!" Adora retorted. "What did they say, anyway?"

And that was also funny! Catra turned to grin at her, wriggling her ears to make her point.

Adora rolled her eyes. "What did they say?"

"Oh, Anise and Freya realised that Sam is in love with Jack, and Jack in love with her, and so they told her that they will stop trying to seduce him."

Adora frowned. "That's a good thing, isn't it? I mean…"

"They will simply try to get his genetic material from now on," Catra interrupted her.

"Oh." Adora blinked. And then she blushed a little. "Not like… that, right?"

Catra shrugged. "I don't think so. But who knows what Tok'ra think about that?"

"Daniel. He would know." Adora nodded. "Let's go ask him!"

That was a good idea. But even better, it proved that Adora was as curious as Catra about this. She grinned widely.

But when she looked around to see if Daniel was still talking to Per'sus, she noticed that Jack had gotten to Daniel first. Damn.

"Oh." Adora pouted. "We can't ask Daniel now - Jack would realise what this is about even if we don't name names."

"So?" That would only make it funnier, in Catra's opinion. And Daniel would probably tell Jack anyway, just as he must have done after his talk with Glimmer.

"We can't just ask Daniel if Anise wants to, ah, just sleep with Jack to have his child if he's there!" Adora hissed.

"Oh." Catra blinked. Not because she agreed with Adora - she didn't; they could and should - but… "I just realised. Anise and Freya want Jack's genetic material to make a baby."

Adora gaped at her. "Oh. But that would… They can't do that!"

Catra nodded. That wasn't funny. You didn't make a baby and then just… left. Both Catra and Adora knew what growing up without parents was like, and growing up with one parent out of the picture because they weren't wanted wasn't good either. It happened too often - on Earth and Etheria - to let it happen to a friend. Or to let a friend let it happen. "We have to talk to them."

"We have to tell Jack," Adora said.

Catra cocked her head. She had meant talking to Anise and Freya, but Jack worked as well - Sam was already trying to tell Anise that they couldn't just make babies. And Entrapta… totally misunderstood the problem. "We need to talk to all of them!" she whispered. "Entrapta just offered to loan Anise and Freya one of the cloning pods from Horde Prime because she thinks this is a *technical* problem."

"Oh, no!" Adora looked from Jack to Sam, Anise and Entrapta and back, biting her lower lip.

"I'll take Jack; you take the others," Catra told her.

“Alright!” Adora nodded, then took a deep breath, raised her chin and started towards the three women on the other side of the buffet.

Catra sighed, grabbed another fried fish and headed to Jack and Daniel.

*****

Jack O’Neill would have to thank Carter once they were back on Earth. The Captain had neatly distracted Anise. Although he would have to be careful so this wouldn’t end up as awkward as their last talk about… similar topics. The last thing Jack wanted was to touch on why Carter had seemed to be annoyed with him as well as with Anise. Or his subordinate’s exact motives for helping him out.

He needed a distraction for himself before he dwelt on that too much and started thinking thoughts a good officer didn’t think about his subordinate. “So, what’s your take on the negotiations?” he asked Daniel before taking the last bit of his alien noodle bowl.

His friend narrowed his eyes slightly. So it was a transparent change of subject - not that talking about the food had been very engaging either, anyway. “I think we’re going to get an Alliance, though ironing out the details might take a little while longer.”

Stating the obvious, are we? But Jack nodded instead of snarking. “Yeah. The Tok’ra might not like it, but they need us if they want to beat the Goa’uld.” They survived until now, but as any officer worth their commission knew, you couldn’t beat an Empire like the Goa’uld’s with just saboteurs and spies. You either needed a revolution with the support of the military - and good luck trying to get the Jaffa to rebel against their gods in sufficient numbers - or an outside power that supported you and could increase the pressure until the Empire cracked. Or defeat it in a war and let you pick up the pieces.

“They need the Alliance, yes,” Daniel said, nodding.

Jack rolled his eyes. “I am aware that ‘us’ doesn’t mean the United States.” Unlike some of his fellow officers, Jack had accepted the new reality. Then again, he had known that the United States wasn’t the top dog any more ever since he had started fighting the snakes. And the Etherians were decent ‘leading allies’, all things considered. Even if they needed to be taught about privacy.

His friend nodded with a smile. “Or just Earth. There’s been a lot of changes since we met the Etherians.”

“Meeting aliens tends to do that,” Jack commented.

“Well, we’ve met aliens before - but we’ve kept it secret, and so any changes were very limited. But now… the whole world knows. This knowledge changes how everyone works and lives. Every country is now at least considering the galaxy when they formulate their policies.”

“And all the riots and economic shockwaves, and, oh, right, the war,” Jack pointed out.

“Well, yes, massive changes rarely happened without such effects in human history.” Daniel didn’t seem to consider that much of a drawback. Then again, he had been willing to live a basically bronze-age life on Abydos with his wife, so Daniel’s standards of what was an ‘acceptable cost’ were a bit off, to say the least.

“You know…” Jack trailed off when he saw Catra walking straight towards them - with a concerned expression. “Don’t tell me you found another spy!” he mumbled, knowing she could hear him.

She jerked at that, her eyes widening, but she kept coming. “No, not a spy,” she said as she reached them. “It’s about making babies, Jack!”

“What?” Jack glanced around. Had someone from their delegation snuck off and was now engaged in the hanky-panky with a snake?

“Making babies?”* Daniel asked.

“Yes. Or, in this case, about not making babies. Jack! You can’t let Anise take your genetic material and make a baby!”

“What?” Jack stared at her.

Now she rolled her eyes. “Duh! What do you think she wants your genetic material for?”

Jack blinked. Not that he would let a snake get his… whatever. But wouldn’t exactly expect Anise to use that to have his babies. Seducing him was one thing - attempting to seduce him - but this was…

“I would have thought they want to analyse it so they can isolate the gene or genes that make you an Ancient - at least according to their AIs,” Daniel said.

“Yes, but that’s just the first step,” Catra said. “What do you think comes once they have that knowledge?”

“They… use it?” Daniel grimaced.

“To make babies with it. Your babies, Jack.”

Oh. Oh damn. Jack hadn’t thought of it like that.

“But just sharing a gene wouldn’t make someone your child,” Daniel said. Then he blinked. “Or would it?”

That wasn’t a question Jack wanted to answer. “I’m not going to have any snake test tube kids,” he said. Charlie would… He pressed his lips together and forced the painful memory away.

“Well, would they be your kids, Jack?” Daniel really didn’t know when to stop. “Or what about, ah, modifying someone’s genes with that gene? Would that make them the donor’s child? Or relative?”

Jack clenched his jaw and glared at his friend, just in time to make him shut up before he could speculate further. “I’m not

going to let anyone get my genetic material for anything like that."

"Good." Catra nodded. "We don't need more kids growing up without their parents."

That… Oh, Hell! That was how the Etherians saw this? Damn. Jack sighed and closed his eyes for a moment. This was even more messed up than he had thought.

"No one will be growing up without parents because I won't let anyone take my genetic material," he said. "No matter what for." Well, Dr Fraser had samples of his blood and stuff, and not just to check if he wasn't replaced with a double on a mission, but that was different.

But Catra didn't look very impressed. "You can't guarantee that."

Jack pressed his lips together. This wasn't a topic to be discussed in the middle of a diplomatic mission in an alien base, but it didn't seem as if he had a choice. He sighed. "Anise won't take my genetic material against my will," he said. "Not if she knows what's good for her."

"She does seem to plan to persuade you." Catra nodded at him.

"No chance," Jack said in a flat voice. He wasn't ready for a kid. Another kid. Not after Charlie.

"I don't think Anise is planning to, ah, make babies," Daniel said. "For one, they would take too long to grow up to help any project."

Ah, Daniel, both ruthless as well as naive. Jack glanced at Catra, who seemed to share his thoughts. "You don't need to be an adult to do things. We were taught how to fight from an early age," she told him.

Of course, she would know this from experience. Jack would really love to have a talk with Hordak about that, no matter how much the alien claimed to have reformed. And speaking of Hordak and

the Horde… "And I'm no expert, but couldn't Horde Prime grow adult clones?" Jack knew that had been the case.

"Right." Catra nodded with a grim expression. "And even if Anise won't do it, others might do it. You might not be able to keep from having… kids."

"I don't know if you could call other people who share some genes with you your kids," Daniel insisted.

"Family, then," Catra retorted.

That was debatable. Only, Jack didn't exactly know how to debate that without sounding as if he would actually abandon family. Even though just getting some genes spliced, modified, whatever didn't make anyone family. Family was more than just genes. Oh, damn - now he sounded like a character out of some sappy soap opera. At least, he was only doing it in his head. "Look," he began, nodding at Catra and Daniel. "I'm not going to abandon a child." Not that there would be one, ever. "But if some Goa'uld adds some of my genes to their Jaffa Prime, then they're no family of mine."

Daniel nodded, but Catra still didn't look convinced. Hell, this argument would have… Oh, for Crying out loud! Jack narrowed his eyes at her. "It's not the same as your situation." Not at all.

"What about Teal'c?"

"He's a special case," Jack replied. Before she could protest, he went on: "And yes, he's not unique. But he's not special because of his, ah, genes, but because of his character. And yes, Daniel's right - you can't just claim to be family like that."

His friend nodded but then said: "Well, I doubt that the question of whether or not you can create familial ties through genetic engineering was ever answered, although they might consider the cases involving sperm donors as precedents."

Jack had no idea whether the rulings from those cases would support his views. He raised his eyebrows at his friend.

"Well, they're not conclusive…" Daniel shrugged. "It depends on the circumstances of the, ah, donation. I'm no expert, though."

"If you have a child, you can't just abandon them," Catra insisted.

"It's not that simple," Daniel said. "Though I think I recall that there have been issues with the biological parent suing the legal parent..."

"Just in case it might be in doubt: I'm not planning to sue for visiting rights to a Jaffa with my genes," Jack said. "And it doesn't matter anyway since I'm not going to let anyone get my genetic material." Oh. That might work. "In fact, I'm going to ask Entrapta to ensure that that can't happen against my will." That should work perfectly. He nodded.

"Ah…" Daniel raised the index of his right hand with a grimace. "Just ensure that there are no misunderstandings. The traditional way to prevent unwanted progeny is kind of… invasive."

Invasive? What…? Jack grimaced himself. "Of course, I didn't mean that!"

Daniel nodded, but Catra looked puzzled. "What do you mean?"

And, not for the first time, Jack's friend was unhelpfully helpful and told her.

"They do that?" Catra asked with wide eyes.

Jack clenched his teeth and debated in his head whether heading over to the other group would be less embarrassing than staying here.

*****

Adora pressed her lips together as she approached her friends. She had to be subtle. Subtle and diplomatic. She needed to be honest and persuasive. She couldn't just tell others what to do - she had to convince them to do the right thing. And, more important, not to do the wrong thing. She could do this. She had to do this.

"You can't make a baby with Jack's genes!"

Adora grimaced as everyone - Anise or Freya, Sam and even Entrapta - looked surprised at her outburst.

"What?" Sam snapped, starting to scowl.

"Actually, you can do it," Entrapta said, nodding. "Science makes it easy - well, relatively easy. But the Horde - Horde Prime's Horde, I mean - already had the necessary technology. Of course, you need the right genetic pattern and base material for the cloning pods - unless you want more Horde clones; that pattern is the default - but it's totally possible to make a baby with Jack's genes! We just have to reverse.engineer the clone pods."

Sam turned her head to frown at Entrapta. "Adora didn't mean that it was impossible."

Adora nodded. "I meant, you shouldn't make babies without their parents to raise them." There - much better! She should have started with that.

"I wouldn't do that!" Anise protested. "Using Jack's genetic material to create offspring without his consent would be an unacceptable breach of trust."

Adora nodded in agreement. That was good. Although now she felt a little foolish for rushing over to her friends. Apparently, she had been worried over nothing. She looked over to see how Catra was doing - she must have overheard their discussion, so… She blinked. Her lover seemed focused on Jack.

“And what would be an acceptable beach of trust?” Sam asked with a twisted smile which, well… Shadow Weaver had always worn a mask, but if she hadn’t, she probably would have had such an expression when she had been annoyed with Adora.

It wasn’t a good look.

Anise cocked her head to the side. “That depends on the circumstances, obviously. What is acceptable and what is not acceptable changes according to the actual situation. If you are trying to preserve your life, more actions are acceptable than when you are merely trying to avoid an inconvenience.”

“The ends justify the means?” Sam was still not happy.

“Yes.” Anise nodded.

Adora shook her head. “That’s not true. Some things are never justified. Like destroying a world to defeat your enemy.” What the First Ones had been planning had been monstrous.

“A single world would be a small price to pay, relatively, to end the threat the Goa’uld present to the entire galaxy,” Anise retorted with a frown. “They have scorched and destroyed multiple worlds during their evil reign.”

But that was… “That doesn’t mean we should do as they do!” Adora protested. “And there’s always a way to defeat them without destroying a world!”

Entrapta nodded. “Yes. Although alternate solutions might not be as effective.”

“That doesn’t matter when we’re talking about innocent lives,” Adora told her.

“Even if it means higher casualties for our own forces?” Anise asked.

“We don’t sacrifice civilians to win,” Adora replied at once. You didn’t attack the helpless! That was what the Horde did! Had done.

“Sometimes, the enemy uses civilians as human shields,” Sam said.

“Then we save the civilians first,” Adora said firmly.

“I see.” Anise nodded. She looked pensive, Adora noticed. Or talking to Freya in her head.

“But we were talking about using Colonel O’Neill’s genetic samples,” Sam said. “Which you still intend to do, don’t you?”

“Well, yes.” Anise nodded. “As an Ancient - or a descendant of an Ancient - his genes could unlock so much technology…”

Adora pressed her lips together as Anise glanced at her. She was a First One - an Ancient - herself.

“Oh, yes!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “Adora helped us so much with using First Ones technology.” She tilted her head to the side. “Although she did that by helping in person. We didn’t clone her or graft her genes on others. Which would be tricky, I think - the First Ones were expert geneticists, so they would have thorough checks for such attempts to bypass their security.”

“Yes. Simply inserting the relevant genes is unlikely to work.” Anise agreed. “The Ancients would have expected such crude methods. And we don’t know how much gene grafting we would have to do to satisfy the requirements set by their technology. However, their own descendants would qualify. We know that already.”

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded. “Alpha proved that when she identified both Adora and Jack as First Ones.”

“Exactly. And that means their progeny would qualify as well,” Anise said. ”Probably - there’s likely a combination of genetic

markers necessary that not every child might inherit."

"So, you do want to make a baby with Jack," Adora said.

"Only with his consent, of course." Anise smiled. "And without sexual intercourse, of course." She nodded at Sam.

Adora blinked again. Uh… "But the baby would still grow up without one parent." And that was bad. Not as bad as being an orphan, but still bad.

Anise's stance changed, and Freya said: "That does not need to be the case. With a Stargate, Colonel O'Neill could easily visit as often as he wanted. With the demands of the war, many children won't see one of their parents for long stretches of time, will they?" She smiled warmly.

That was… She wasn't wrong, Adora had to admit. And if Jack agreed to that, well, she couldn't tell anyone not to have children, could she? Wait, she had just done that - but that had been different.

"The Colonel won't agree," Sam said with a scowl.

"That remains to be seen," Freya said. "Of course, he could raise the child - or children - and we could visit. I am sure he would be a good parent."

Adora blinked. She wasn't the only one. That was… well, Jack had had a child, so he had experience, but… he was also very busy. But… "That would be his decision," she said. But she doubted he would want to raise a child during the war - he would have to quit the Air Force, wouldn't he?

Sam shook her head. "He won't."

But Freya kept smiling, and Adora didn't think Sam sounded as certain as before.

This was getting complicated.

*****

The Colonel wouldn't give consent to having a test tube baby with an alien. Samantha Carter was confident that her assessment of him was correct. Mostly - she wasn't a hundred per cent certain. And, she realised, she didn't know enough to tell. She knew - from talking to others; he had never talked about it, and Sam knew better than to bring it up - that the Colonel had lost his son to a tragic accident with a firearm three years ago, which had also destroyed his marriage.

But would that push him to reject Anise's offer? He was almost certainly blaming himself for the accident; any parent would in his position. So Anise's offer might be seen as a sort of second chance. Unlikely, but not impossible. And since Sam knew, from personal observation and experience, that the Colonel had a soft spot for kids, possibly accentuated because of this tragedy, she was also reasonably sure that if someone managed to create a test tube baby with his genetic material, he wouldn't reject the child.

But she didn't know for certain how he felt. And not just about the issue of test tube babies. Another reason for not breaking regulations, a small voice whispered in her head. If she never found out the truth, she couldn't be disappointed.

She pushed the voice away. She wasn't afraid of the truth. And she wouldn't let fear dictate her course of action. Complying with regulations was the reasonable course of action, nothing more, nothing less.

But she still felt the urge to punch Anise - and Freya; both were in obvious agreement about their plans - in the face. It was irrational and unfair, she knew that. They were from an alien culture. Two alien cultures, actually, and they were, as far as Sam was aware, acting perfectly acceptable according to their standards. And, she added to herself, according to some standards of Earth and possibly Etheria as well - donating sperm and oocytes was a relatively common procedure, after all.

But trying to trap someone in a relationship by having their child was not too rare either in many cultures, she added with a frown.

"Well…" Adora broke the short spell of silence. "That would be his decision, right?"

Of course, it would be the Colonel's decision! Sam nodded sharply.

But Freya kept smiling so confidently. She knew nothing about the Colonel, Sam knew. Anise and Freya only knew of his reputation and fame and had barely spent a day with him, less than twenty-four hours in total. Sam had spent months with the man, much of it in extreme situations where people generally showed their true colours, but they had also spent considerable time socialising.

She raised her head and met their eyes. Yes, she told herself again, the Colonel would reject their offer.

He'd better!

*****

"...so, you see, it's technically reversible, but the odds aren't that good. So, it's practically a final decision not to have any more children."

Catra didn't grimace at Daniel's explanation, but she couldn't help feeling a bit queasy at the thought of asking a healer to permanently remove her ability to have a child. Although healing magic should be able to reverse that. Of course, with Entrapta's help, she could have a child with Adora any time she wanted, no matter the condition of her body - and in a pinch, Adora could carry a baby to term, though they would have to find out how transforming into She-Ra would affect that - but to do that to your own body? When you had other alternatives?

She shook her head. "That feels like a pretty drastic way to save on money spent on contraception."

"Well…" Daniel shrugged with a sheepish expression. "It's one of the most effective ways. And you, ah, can't forget or mess it up. But it is not an uncontroversial procedure; many men think, although quite irrationally, that it would hurt their masculinity."

"Ah." Well, cutting something in your body might do that - Catra was no expert on Earth culture. "But you don't cut off their balls."

"No, we don't. Not any more, at least," Daniel said.

"I think we all got your History of Eunuchs 101 lesson," O'Neill cut in with a toothy smile. "Thank you."

Daniel pouted at his friend. "I felt it was important to explain the differences between a vasectomy and castration. You really cannot afford any misunderstandings here."

O'Neill tensed and nodded jerkily.

Catra agreed. "And it wouldn't help you anyway since Anise could take your genetic material from any cell." At least, Entrapta could do that, so Anise should be able to do it as well.

"Yes, I assume so."

"So, how exactly do you expect her to keep your, ah, genetic legacy secure?" Daniel asked.

For a moment, Jack frowned, then he smiled and shrugged. "Magic?"

Daniel snorted, but Catra nodded. That sounded like it might work. "You should ask Glimmer, though. She's the one who was trained as a sorceress. Entrapta's the specialist for technology."

"I will then."

Catra narrowed her eyes. She couldn't tell if O'Neill was serious or not. He sounded serious, and it was a serious subject, but… he also didn't like magic.

Well, it was his body, so it was his choice and none of her business. And if he could get over his dislike of magic, then that could only help him.

*****

And he would. Jack O'Neill was sure of that. He suppressed a shudder. Magic was creepy, but he would rather have a spell cast on him than find out someone made a test tube baby with his genes. Or a clone. Or an alien-O'Neill clone. Yes, despite the creepiness, he would talk to Glimmer about this.

But not right now. This was a diplomatic meeting, after all, and Glimmer was the most important member of the Alliance delegation. Mostly because she was more of a diplomat than Adora, of course. In any case, Jack knew better than to bother her about his personal problems in the middle of diplomatic negotiations. Even though they were currently being conducted at the buffet. With his luck, he might derail a crucial breakthrough by distracting her - the Etherians might take politics personally, but, as Catra had just proven again, they cared about their friends so much, they might prioritise Jack's issues over the good of the Alliance.

And that, Jack wouldn't allow. Couldn't. He knew his duty to his country and to Earth. And he would be a damn hypocrite if he defended Air Force fraternisation regulations to the Etherians, then turned around and asked them to help him with a personal problem at the expense of the overall goal of the Alliance.

No, there was enough time to handle this once they were back on Earth. More privacy as well - Jack wasn't keen on letting everyone know he wanted to use magic to keep aliens from taking his genetic material. Carter would probably call it 'preventive contraception' or something sciency-sounding, but she would do it with that faint smile of hers that…

Jack sighed and grabbed another bowl of alien noodles. He reminded himself that he knew his duty. And that he would do his

duty.

And just as he started to eat - Daniel was well into lecturing Catra about the finer points of masculinity as seen by various cultures on Earth - the Head Snake called everyone to the meeting room again.

Great. Jack started shovelling food into his mouth on the way to the door. He had a feeling he'd need the calories.

*****

"...and yes, I think we can agree on the necessity of a united intelligence council. However, the exact composition and purview of such a council need to be defined more clearly before we can move to the next part."

Jack O'Neill struggled not to yawn. Sir Watson had the boring, droning tone of a bureaucrat down pat. The man could speak far more engagedly, Jack knew that, so either he was feeling the hours himself, or this was by design - it was hard to tell with career diplomats. Not that Jack could think of a reason why you wanted to be boring unless it was to tire out the other side or make them fall asleep at the table.

Which, he confirmed with a glance around, wasn't working anyway. At least not on the snakes and their hosts. Though they probably cheated by switching between Goa'uld and host so one of them could rest. Or something.

But Catra looked like she was only awake because Adora would elbow her if she fell asleep, and even Daniel seemed to be too tired to keep paying a hundred per cent attention to 'history being made in our presence', as he had called it. Before the meeting, of course.

"Indeed," Garhsaw said. "And, given the importance of intelligence for waging war, I think the council's purview should include some oversight on how the information provided and curated by it is being used."

"As long as that is strictly limited to advising, of course," Glimmer cut in. "We cannot allow such a council to usurp the role of command."

Sir Watson nodded, and Garshaw smiled. "Of course." Jack couldn't tell if she had seriously expected to be able to outmanoeuvre the Alliance like that, but he was sure that she wouldn't have minded if the spook council would have gotten veto powers or something. It certainly would have fit the sneaky snakes to try for some 'rule from the shadows' role, and you couldn't get more shadowy in war than a spy.

But with that line drawn, they settled for the details of how to staff said council. Surprisingly, the Etherians didn't propose some magical superspy as the leader of the council. Or not so surprisingly - Jack remembered that they didn't seem to be terribly fond of spies, the way they sometimes spoke of 'Double Trouble'.

Well, Jack approved of being wary of spooks. Based on his own experience with them - he was sure that the Etherian version of spies wasn't any better than the CIA agents he had worked with during the Cold War. Probably worse since they had all sorts of magic.

While Glimmer, who seemed to be holding up well, actually, and Sir Watson hashed out the details with Garshaw and Per'sus, Jack risked a glance at Anise, who was taking part in the meetings as a technological advisor - and immediately wished he hadn't. The snake met his eyes with a smile. Or Freya did; Jack couldn't tell right now, not without them talking or moving.

Two people - or a snake and a person - occupying the same body was just creepy. How were you supposed to have a relationship with that, anyway? What if you liked one but not the other? What if you liked both but preferred one? Or if one of them hated you, and the other loved you? It was difficult enough to handle a relationship with just one person, especially as a soldier - Jack's marriage had seen some rocky times even before… He pressed his

lips together as he, once more today, had to force the memories of that terrible day away. Anyway, handling a relationship with two people? That would be a nightmare.

No, Jack would stick to plain boring relationships with a single partner. Hypothetically, of course, since regulations were regulations, and they forbid relationships between an officer and a subordinate.

*****

Adora suppressed a sigh when the meeting finally ended. Almost midnight Earth time, according to her watch, but it wasn't the hours, it was the drudge, or what you called it. Catra, of course, wasn't nearly as subtle or diplomatic. "Finally!" she exclaimed when Glimmer, Sir Watson and Garshaw agreed on finishing for today. "I think I fell asleep twice already!"

Everyone chuckled, though Adora wasn't quite sure that her lover had been joking - there had been a few spots during the last two hours or so during which Adora had been too absorbed by the discussions to pay enough attention to Catra. And since those discussions had been more political than military, Catra might not have cared enough for them to pay rapt attention herself.

Well, it was over for now. And they had made progress! Sure, the devil was in the details, but a lot of the big stuff had been settled. More or less, at least. Adora trusted Glimmer and Sir Watson would handle the rest. Of course, this was just the preliminary negotiations, so there were still important subjects left for the elected leaders of the Earth countries to discuss and settle. Though as Sir Watson had explained, if the preliminary meetings were going well, odds were the actual official negotiations wouldn't divert too much from what the diplomats had already sounded out.

It was different from what Adora was used to. On Etheria, princesses handled that kind of stuff - preliminary meetings were mostly about protocol and stuff setting up the actual meetings

since you needed a princess to actually make decisions, but then, since they had Glimmer and Adora herself here, that wasn't a problem.

Still… she was glad to return home, or sort of home, now. "I'd rather fight a tank platoon than do this again," she muttered before she caught herself.

Catra snickered. "Of course, you would," she said. "Tossing around tanks is fun for you."

One of the officers in the delegation walking behind them laughed aloud. General… Peck, Adora confirmed with a glance. The American.

"You should have seen her whine about not being allowed to throw tanks back when we were fighting mind-controlled allies," Catra told him with a smirk, walking backwards as they left the meeting room.

"Throw tanks back?" Peck laughed some more.

Adora pouted. "Scorpia was throwing tanks at us!"

"One tank," Catra said. "And she later apologised for that."

The general suddenly looked a little confused.

"They're not pulling your leg, sir," Jack chimed in. "There are at least two individual Etherians who can physically throw light tanks like we'd throw a backpack."

"*At least* light tanks," Catra said.

Adora nodded. They hadn't tried it with heavier tanks since the Horde didn't have them.

"The antigravity engines throw off the equations a little," Entrapta said. "But both Scorpia and Adora should be able to handle the mass."

The general wasn't laughing any more, Adora noticed. And Per'sus was staring at them as well. "I thought we mentioned that," she commented. She was sure they had. Pretty sure.

"It was in our report," Jack said. "But it might have been dismissed as an exaggeration."

"I must have missed it," Peck said. He added something else under his breath that Adora didn't catch, but Catra snickered again, so it was probably a curse.

Ah, well - they could address their allies' lack of knowledge about their capabilities later. Right now, Adora really wanted to return to her bed and rest. And relax.

They reached the transport room, but it took a few more minutes of shaking hands and saying their goodbyes before they were finally off, and then there was still the trip back to the Stargate.

There was something to be said for placing the Stargate close to or into one of your bases, Adora found. It cut down on travel time a lot.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 15th, 1998

Adora sighed without restraint when she walked down the ramp in Stargate Command's gate room. Almost home! Well, almost back to Darla.

But the generals were already waiting for them. Four of them - the French one was missing. "Good to have you back," General Hammond said. "Was there any trouble?"

"The Stargate worked like a charm, sir," Jack replied. "No security concerns either." He shrugged with a glance at the Russian general. "I think that's all that concerns Stargate Command."

The Russian general glared at him, which prompted Catra to chuckle. Adora almost chimed in before she caught herself - she must be a little more tired than she had thought.

“Alright, Colonel. The Alliance delegation is waiting at NORAD to debrief you.”

Right, Adora reminded herself. Officially, Stargate Command wasn’t an Allied base but under United Nations control, so the Alliance officials would be waiting in the base right above this one.

Earth customs were weird sometimes. Not too rarely, actually.

“More meetings,” Catra whined. “Let’s just tell them we’ll talk to them tomorrow! At noon!”

“And leave us to face them all alone?” Jack frowned at her.

“Yes.” She beamed at him, showing all her teeth.

“That would be selfish,” Glimmer said, shaking her head.

“So? Don’t tell me you want to have another meeting right now,” Catra shot back.

“It’s not about what we want, but about what we need to do,” Glimmer replied. “So…”

“Oh, great!” Entrapta cried out, interrupting them - she was talking into her multitool, Adora realised. And she smiled widely. “The relay network is done!” she announced. “We can talk to our friends back on Etheria! And a few days earlier than projected, even!”

Adora gasped, then smiled.

Yes!

“We need to return to Darla at once,” Glimmer said.

“Oh, now we do?” Catra asked - but she was smiling as well.

“Sorry,” Adora told Jack with a smile.

Though she didn’t feel too sorry. She really wanted to talk to her friends back home. She hadn’t seen them in almost half a year!

*****

Going Home Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 15th, 1998

"Sorry! We'd really love to attend a boring debriefing, but talking to our friends back home is more important."

Glimmer didn't really sound sorry, in Samantha Carter's opinion. Adora and Bow at least looked embarrassed, but Catra was grinning widely, and Entrapta… was still talking with the fleet in orbit.

"So… see you tomorrow, I guess. Or later today, technically," Glimmer nodded at them as the lift stopped, then stepped out of the cabin and headed to the lift leading to the ground level. "Bye!"

"Well, I guess it's just us now," the Colonel said as the Etherians all but charged into the lift. "Us and the brass. And the politicians. Can't forget them - trust me, I've tried."

Sam drew a sharp breath, but Sir Watson, who was standing right behind them, chuckled. "I would mention that we're diplomats, not politicians, but I assume you do not think that there's much of a difference."

"Well, since you generally do what the politicians say, not really," the Colonel replied.

"As do soldiers, I believe - at least in civilised countries," the British diplomat retorted, still smiling.

The Colonel frowned. "That's a low blow!"

"I don't think either war or diplomacy is a game or athletic competition, Colonel O'Neill."

"War has rules, though."

"But pointing out that both soldiers and diplomats are under the authority of the government - and, therefore, under the authority of politicians - does not violate the rules of war, Colonel."

"Well, it should!"

Sam suppressed a sigh as both men chuckled. It was late already, and she wasn't looking forward to the debriefing. Not at all. And with the news that the Etherians had finally reestablished contact with their home planet, the debriefing would take even longer. Sam was sure of that. Even though everyone should be aware that SG-1 didn't know anything more than what everyone else knew - that they could talk to Etheria.

And they had arrived at the meeting room - guarded by a squad of marines. And a number of people in suits. Oh.

The Colonel stiffened as well at the sight. Soldiers were expected. But bodyguards? That meant a high-ranking official was waiting for them.

And since Sam thought she recognised at least one of the bodyguards from her visits to the White House…

She straightened as she entered the room - behind the Colonel, who was walking behind General Peck and Sir Watson himself.

"Mr President!"

Yes, as expected, there was the President waiting for them. She heard Daniel gasp next to her - he must have missed the signs. The Colonel, of course, wasn't surprised.

The President returned the general's salute and shook Sir Watson's hand. "Please have a seat. I know you must be tired, but I don't think this can wait. Especially not with the news that our allies now can talk with their home planet." He gestured towards the table, where more politicians - foreigners, Sam noted; she recognised the Canadian Prime Minister and the NATO Secretary General sitting there. Amongst the others would be

representatives of the United Kingdom, France and Germany then. Their allies in NATO, but while the US joining the Alliance against the Goa'uld was, according to everything she had heard, a done deal, it hadn't been formally signed yet - though that should happen any day as soon as the last detail was cleared. Unless something significant happened that could derail the process.

Yes, as she had feared. This wouldn't be a debriefing about the diplomatic meeting with the Tok'ra but also a briefing about the Etherian situation. Or, as Sam suspected, a lot of speculation, most of which would be rendered obsolete in the morning when the Etherians would return to talk.

But, as Sir Watson had pointed out, both diplomats and soldiers served their government, and it was very obvious that their governments wanted to discuss the situation right here and now.

She forced herself to focus. She was, first of all, an officer in the Air Force and would do her duty to the best of her ability.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 15th, 1998

Catra smirked when Glimmer all but jumped on the ramp as soon as the shuttle had stopped in Darla's hangar - before the ramp had even touched the floor. "We could have relayed the signal to the shuttle if you're so eager," she said - to the princess's back; Glimmer was already rushing to the door.

"I asked if we should," Entrapta said behind her. "You said you could wait a few more minutes."

"She probably didn't want to appear too eager," Catra said with a smirk and shrug.

"Ah."

"She hasn't seen Micah in months," Adora said.

"And apparently forgot that she can teleport," Catra said with a chuckle.

Her lover looked at the door - through which Glimmer, followed by Bow, just disappeared, and Catra knew she was just holding back from rushing after them herself. Adora was missing her friends back on Etheria.

Catra… well, it would be great to talk to them. Catch up. She was wondering how Scorpia and Perfuma were doing. And how the Princess Alliance and Second Fleet were doing, of course. Of course, Catra didn't really worry too much about them. Etheria was not known to the Goa'uld, or shouldn't be, thanks to the system having been sealed in a pocket dimension for a thousand years. And even though the princesses she trusted most were here on Earth, the other Elemental Princesses should be able to keep the planet safe and the Alliance going. You could never be sure, though.

But the most important person for Catra - by far - was at her side. She didn't have to rush to the bridge to call home. Home was where Adora was. She grabbed Adora's hand as they stepped into the corridor leading to the bridge and squeezed.

Adora smiled at her and squeezed back.

Then they reached the bridge, where Glimmer was freaking out. "Do I have any stains anywhere? I don't want to look like we're in trouble or something," she asked Bow.

"Relax, Glimmer. You're perfect. I would have told you if you didn't look good."

Catra snickered at the scowl that comment caused to appear on Glimmer's face.

"But we've just spent hours in a diplomatic meeting! Negotiating!"

"And you look fine," Adora told her.

Catra was tempted to make a comment but refrained. Glimmer did look OK, anyway. "So… what's the holdup?" she asked. "I would have expected you to have called already.

"We were waiting for you," Glimmer said with another scowl as if she had expected them to run as well.

Well, good luck with that! Catra leaned against Adora's seat. "So, let's get ready for the call?"

"It's ready," Entrapta said. "We can open a line of communication anytime we want! The network is stable, and the lag should be minimal. That means no more than six seconds because of all the relays. I can't reduce that further, sorry."

"It's OK," Glimmer told her.

"Given the distance and technical limitations, that's a great achievement," Bow added with a smile.

"Well, Sam helped a lot with the setup and programming - and we copied some protocols from the Internet of Earth, although mostly for redundancy. It's not doing much for speed, and while the basics of data transfers are similar, Faster-than-light communication lag can't be helped overly much by protocols for optical or even electronic networks."

Glimmer was sitting on the edge of her seat and doing her best not to bite her lips, Catra noticed. Well, Catra could ask Entrapta to go into some detail, but that would be cruel.

"Let's start the call, then," Adora said.

The screen lit up with a rotating symbol - Entrapta's work; it looked like a stylised bot - while the call went out. Six seconds, she had said. Catra counted, then slid into Adora's lap just as the screen changed and King Micah appeared.

"Glimmer!"

“Dad!” Glimmer cried out, followed by a sniffle.

She must have been really worried, Catra realised. Well, for over a decade, Glimmer had thought that Micah had been killed by the Horde. That would have left an effect.

“How are you doing? We’ve been waiting for a courier to return,” Micah said. His eyes were glittering a bit as well. Catra hoped he wouldn’t start crying. Glimmer would follow at once, and so would Adora.

“Yes, we decided that creating a permanent network of bots serving as comm relays would be more efficient than using couriers,” Entrapta explained. “Six seconds of lag is better than a few months, right?”

Micah continued. “So, we were very relieved when we received news that you made contact. And then worried when it was from a bot.”

“Yes, Dad, but this way, we can talk any time we want,” Glimmer said.

“Ah, that explains it. Thank you, Entrapta.”

“I’m working on reducing it further, Micah.”

Well, a lag of six seconds didn’t sound like much, but it made talking a bit awkward, Catra realised as Micah and Glimmer kept talking just past each other.

“We need to space out our answers.” Glimmer had realised the same thing.

Six seconds later, Micah nodded on screen. “Yes. So…”

Then Scorpia appeared behind him, grinning widely. “Hey, wildcat!” She waved, and her pincer hid most of Micah for a moment. “How are you doing.”

Catra smiled. “Doing good. Even though the humans - the Tau’ri, as you know them - are crazy.”

“They aren’t crazy!” Adora protested. “Only some of them.”

“Scorpia!” Entrapta beamed at her.

Micah cleared his throat.

“Oh, sorry - I thought we could talk,” Scorpia told him.

“Dear, Micah hasn’t seen Glimmer in months.” Perfuma appeared on the screen as well.

What were they doing in Bright Moon? Catra wondered. There hadn’t been enough time since the contact had been made for them to travel from the Fright Zone - former Fright Zone - to Bright Moon. She would have expected them to join through a routed call.

“We made an Alliance with Earth - well, some countries on Earth,” Adora being Adora, explained while the other side was still talking to each other.

“Ugh. Let them talk!” That was Mermista. Was there an Alliance meeting?

“An alliance?” Micah cocked his head.

“Do they really have billions of people on their planet?” Perfuma asked. “How do they feed them?”

Glimmer looked like she was a little annoyed as she replied: “Yes, Dad, we made an Alliance with the leading countries of Earth. And we’re working on an Alliance with the Tok’ra - they are fighting the Goa’uld, but they’re, biologically, the same species.”

Then another face appeared as they waited for an answer. WrongHordak. “Hello!” He smiled at them. “Sorry, I got delayed. Did you tell them about the attack already?”

Catra blinked. “The attack?” she said together with her friends.

“Not yet.”

“We were about to.”

“Can someone move the camera a bit back?”

Six seconds could feel like an eternity, Catra realised as she waited for their friends to hear their question.

Then Micah stopped smiling - a bad sign. “Ah. We were attacked during your absence.” He glanced at WrongHordak.

“Yes.” The clone nodded - and he had also stopped smiling. That was an even worse sign.

“By whom?” Adora blurted out. She was very tense.

WrongHordak answered her question before he heard it: “Elements of a Horde fleet that was detached to suppress an insurrection - at least that’s what we assume based on their communication - arrived in the system. We hailed them and told them what happened, but they didn’t take the news about Horde Prime’s death well.” He grimaced. “They blamed us for ‘betraying’ him and attacked. We were forced to destroy them - they wouldn’t surrender or even attempt to retreat.”

Catra muttered a curse under her breath. It would have been easier if it had been the Goa’uld. Probably. “Do you know if there are more of them?” she asked.

“How many ships did they have?” Glimmer asked.

“Did you lose people?” Adora leaned forward a little.

Seconds passed. Catra clenched her teeth so she wouldn’t blurt out more questions. That would only make it harder to get the information she wanted. Damn, she really hated the lag.

Finally, WrongHordak heard their questions. “Ah… We were, unfortunately, unable to confirm whether or not the ships we saw were the entirety of the detached fleet elements. We did not detect any communication with others, though; that much we can state with certainty. They had three squadrons - usually more than enough to deal with a rebellion on a planet, but there were larger deployments in the past, according to First Fleet’s archives.” He bowed his head. “We lost half a dozen ships. We didn’t expect their attack, so we were unprepared. I was… too optimistic. I am deeply sorry.”

“It wasn’t your fault,” Adora told him at once.

Catra didn’t quite agree - given how different Third and Second Fleet had turned out after Horde Prime’s death, and how the remnants of First Fleet had clung to Hordak, WrongHordak should have expected that there might be some hardcore loyalist forces - but this wasn’t the time to sort that out.

“We have increased readiness, though, so that won’t happen again,” WrongHordak finished.

“This was two months ago,” Micah said. “And there hasn’t been another contact since.”

“We’ve sent scouting detachments out,” WrongHordak explained. “But we kept the bulk of our forces in the system, and we haven’t found another fleet element.”

Or another fleet. But there could be one out there, Catra knew. Or even several. Horde Prime had kept too much information in his head, off his data banks - no one knew how many ships and clones he’d had under his command at the end. Or where they are. With each fleet having its own supply train, and most ships having been built in his flagship, which was now a space plant, there was no useful data to sift through, either.

“I see.” Glimmer nodded. “It seems you have the situation in hand. Now, about our alliances…”

As Glimmer proceeded to fill the others back on Etheria in about how things had gone on Earth, Catra pondered how to handle this new problem. They would have to spread the spy bot network out even more than planned; that was obvious. But they also would have to make a plan for handling more Horde remnants. They couldn't fight a peer opponent and the Goa'uld at the same time.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 15th, 1998

Jack O'Neill clenched his jaw. You didn't yawn in the President's presence. No matter how long a day you'd had and how late - or early - it was. And, a quick glance at the clock on the wall confirmed, it was getting very late indeed. Not quite so late that it started to become morning, but he really wanted to crash in his bunk. In the base - he was too tired to return home. Probably too tired to drive, at least in civilian traffic.

But the meeting wasn't over yet.

"...and so I believe that the Etherians will ask for help restoring the Stargate on Etheria. Which, in this case, means adding either a D.H.D. or a replacement like the installation we use at Stargate Command. Both options are within our capabilities," Carter finished her technical assessment.

"But the D.H.D. is Russian," the Secretary of State remarked. "They'll want their pound of flesh for parting with it and then some. Probably access to advanced technology as if they were in the Alliance."

"Would the Etherians agree to that?"

"No," Jack said. Damn - he had spoken up without being prompted. He must be more tired than he had thought. "They won't agree to that. In my opinion."

Daniel followed his lead. “I agree. They haven’t shown any inclination to change their stance on the minimum conditions for sharing technology.”

“I see.” The President looked relieved. “And how fast could we provide them with a copy of Stargate Command’s, ah, installation?” He looked at Carter.

“A copy of the installation at Stargate Command would take several weeks to a month,” Carter replied. She probably had calculated that long ago. “However, that would be inefficient. The Etherian computer and power technology allows for a more efficient setup to be developed. We would only need to share our database. About a week, I would say, at the longest.”

“And then a month to transport it back to their home planet?” a foreign politician asked. German, according to the accent.

“No,” Carter replied at once. “The Stargate on Etheria cannot open a wormhole to another gate, lacking a control device, but other Stargates can connect to it as soon as it is recovered from where we sealed it. We can send the control device replacement as well as a team to set it up through our Stargate.”

And Jack would bet a month’s worth of the good jello in the canteen that Carter and Entrapta had the whole setup prepared already and were only waiting for the order to go ahead.

Hell, he was pretty sure that they would go ahead even without official permission if the government dragged its heels. Probably with some flimsy excuse that the Etherians developed it themselves.

And Jack would back them on that. Even a complete idiot would realise that they needed a Stargate on Etheria, Jack was sure about that. But he wasn’t as sure that everyone realised that this was too important to play power games or attempt some horse-trading to gain an advantage.

The Etherians wouldn't take well to that. Unlike most on Earth, they had been fighting a war for years, decades even. And that sort of thing shaped you and your views.

He blinked. Damn, he really needed sleep - he started to sound like Daniel in his head.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 15th, 1998

"...and that's the current situation," Glimmer finished summing up the state of their negotiations with the Tok'ra. "We expect the alliance to be formalised within the next few weeks."

Adora nodded - that was what Sir Watson had said as well. And if everything went well, the United States would formally join the Alliance before that - even though it was, as Sir Watson liked to say, a *de facto* member already.

"Provided the Earth leaders don't mess up." Catra snorted. "It wouldn't surprise me. Over," she added with a glance at Glimmer before she leaned back against Adora while they waited for the response from their friends.

Glimmer frowned at her in return. Adora gave her a smile and a shrug - Glimmer had forgotten to tell the others that it was their turn to talk, so Catra wasn't at fault for adding it. And all of them had agreed that using old Earth radio protocols was a good idea to make communication easier and less chaotic with the annoying lag.

Bow patted Glimmer's hand.

Then, on the screen, Micah nodded. "I see. That's good news."

"Yes," Perfuma agreed. "More allies is always a good thing. And it proves that the Goa'uld can change." She blinked. "But they don't like being called Goa'uld, the Tok'ra, right?"

Adora owned her mouth, then waited. They hadn't given the signal to talk yet.

"Ugh." Mermista sighed. "Over."

"Yes, they don't like it," Adora said, nodding. "They don't consider themselves Goa'uld, actually."

"Just treat the Goa'uld and the Tok'ra as different kingdoms," Glimmer said. "Or like the Horde and the Princess Alliance. Over."

Another six-second pause. And they couldn't really talk since they were still transmitting. Maybe they should turn the transmission off? As if it were a radio from those old Earth war movies? But that would feel weird. And they wouldn't be able to watch their friends then. Just turn the microphone off? That would feel a little rude.

"We will do that." Perfuma beamed. "And we have an alliance with Earth!"

"With some of their kingdoms," Mermista corrected her. "Which aren't kingdoms. Whatever."

"The best kingdoms of Earth," Scorpia said. "Like the Princess Alliance has the best kingdoms of Etheria."

"And the best of the Horde." WrongHordak was smiling widely again. "I am happy to hear that Priest hasn't caused trouble. Much, at least."

Catra snorted again.

"So…" Micah turned to face the others in his room. "For the record: Does anyone oppose the decisions taken by Glimmer, Adora and Entrapta in the name of the Princess Alliance?"

Adora bit her lower lip. She didn't expect them to disagree, but…

"Of course not!" Perfuma said.

“No,” Scorpia added. “Good work.”

Mermista snorted, then shook her head. “I mean, no.”

“No,” WrongHordak said. Then he blinked. “Although I wasn’t aware that we had a veto.”

“We don’t, technically,” Micah told him. “Glimmer, Adora and Entrapta were mandated by the Princess Alliance to conduct the exact negotiations that they then did.”

“Ah.”

Adora saw Glimmer shift in her seat, pressing her lips together. She obviously wanted to say something.

“I doubt Netossa and Spinnerella will disagree, and Frosta probably won’t, either,” Micah said. “Though you’ll have to talk to Castaspella about the magic issues. Over.”

“I will,” Glimmer said. “Where are they, anyway? Over.”

Right. Adora would have expected the rest of their friends to be present - at least via comm.

Micah blushed a little. “Ah, we didn’t want to disturb them. They’re resting - it’s the middle of the night here.”

Oh. Adora had forgotten about the time differences.

Mermista snorted again. “That’s what you call it?”

“Frosta is resting,” Micah said. “In her palace. We informed her people, of course, but it’s up to them whether or not they wake her up. Netossa and Spinerella didn’t want to be disturbed.”

That meant they were… Ah. Adora felt her cheeks heat up a little, and Catra snickered.

“They’re gonna hate that they missed this,” Cara mumbled.

“Their own fault, then,” Glimmer said.

“Can we speak now? Anyway.” Entrapta smiled. “We need to get Etheria’s Stargate working again - then we can visit any time we want. So, you need to excavate the gate and set it up so we can send a control unit to you. Once we finish it - we need some data still. And a power supply. And you probably need some security for the gate. I have some ideas about bots and gun emplacement. We also might want a huge bomb to blow it up, just in case - Sam said they have such a bomb at Stargate Command. Uh, over!”

Micah and the others nodded as they listened to Entrapta, but Adora could tell that they didn’t like the ‘huge bomb’ part. Well, they probably didn’t need that part of the security. Not if the rest held up.

“Ah. Yes, that sounds like a good idea - though we can iron out the security details later, I think,” Micah said. “So, you will be able to return to Etheria? Over.”

“Yes. Though we have a lot of work to do here, with the Stargate, we’ll be able to travel back and forth easily - and to any other planet with a Stargate,” Glimmer said with a wide smile.

“Hence the need for security,” Catra said.

Glimmer frowned a little. “But we’ll also have to decide how to handle travel in general. There are a lot of humans - Tau’ri - who want to visit Etheria. And, well… that could cause some trouble. Especially if they want to visit other kingdoms that aren’t in the Alliance. Over.”

“Oh, yes,” Catra mumbled.

Adora agreed. But compared to finally being able to see and visit their friends again, it was a small thing.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 15th, 1998

Almost noon. Samantha Carter felt as if she had overslept the whole morning. She knew it was irrational - the meeting with the President had lasted until early morning, and she had barely caught five hours of sleep - but she never started her day this late.

She pushed the guilt away as she stepped out of the lift on her floor. Now that work was to be done, she wouldn't waste any more of her time.

"Ah, good morning!" Iwan greeted her in the hallway. "I heard you have eventful day, da? No science, but plenty political!"

Was he fishing for information? It wasn't a secret that the Alliance was negotiating with the Tok'ra. And the Etherians hadn't kept the news that they had reestablished communications with their home planet secret either. And if anyone thought that the President visiting Cheyenne Mountain would be ignored by anyone in the base… She shrugged and deliberately yawned. "Yes. It got very late."

"Ah, yes. Ours is not to reason why, da?"

Tennyson. Of course, a Russian might know a poem about the Crimean War. "We're not the Light Brigade," she replied. "A lengthy meeting won't kill us."

"Not here, but in Soviet Russia, it might very well have killed us. By alcohol poisoning or firing squad." He laughed. "Good thing there's no more Soviet Russia. Would be awkward to court other princesses on Etheria as soviets, da? After we shoot Tsar and princesses."

Ah. Of course, that Russia and China - and many other countries - would want to open diplomatic relations with other Etherian kingdoms was obvious as well. Sam nodded. "Provided the Etherians open their Stargate for travelling."

“You think the Princess Alliance will keep the Stargate closed for rest of Etheria?”

Was that his angle? Did he want information - intelligence - about the political situation on Etheria? Or her views of the Princess Alliance? “I don’t know,” she said. “That’s up to the Princess Alliance.” It was a political decision, and she was a scientist.

“Ah.”

No comment about her close friendship with Entrapta. But as she walked towards her lab, he was walking with her.

“Will there be a Stargate Command Etheria, maybe? Independent organisation of Etherians?” He shrugged. “Etherians wanted to talk to entire Earth, so only fair if we do the same?”

That was true, of course. And Sam was sure that her friends would struggle with the implied hypocrisy. “Etheria doesn’t have a United Nations,” Sam pointed out. “The Princess Alliance is the closest organisation they have to the United Nations.”

“So, Etheria is ruled by Princess NATO?” Iwan laughed, turning it into a joke.

Sam nodded. “They were at war for decades, and they’re at war again.” And that would influence their actions. Only, Sam didn’t know in what direction.

They reached the door to her lab, and she nodded at him. “Have a nice day.”

He smiled back. “You too! Don’t stay too late today!”

She snorted. Although she was planning to stay a little longer - she had a feeling she would have to.

Once she was inside her lab, and the door was closed, she grabbed the VR glasses and switched the Waldo controls on. A

moment later, she was staring at the inside of the spacelab. "Entrapta?"

No answer. That meant her friend wasn't in the lab. But she, or a bot of hers, would be listening, so…

A hologram appeared next to her. "Sam! I was wondering why you weren't around in the morning!" Entrapta beamed at her.

"I had a meeting late at night," Sam told her. "So I slept in."

"Ah!" Entrapta nodded - and then yawned. "Maybe I should have slept in as well. But we were talking with our friends, and then there was so much to do. Still is, actually."

"I can imagine." Sam wouldn't go fishing for information. Entrapta was her friend.

"Oh! We need our gate controller finished," Entrapta said. "Can we use your computer data?"

Sam had expected that. And she winced. "I asked, but it's currently in dispute if the data is the sole property of Stargate Command or if the US Government has a claim as well."

"Huh?" Entrapta's hologram blinked. "But you gathered the data!"

"Yes, but the agreement that transferred Stargate Command to the United Nations apparently is a bit unclear about that point." Sam frowned. Russia and China were, in a blatant attempt to extort concessions, claiming that the data was part of the Stargate and, therefore, entirely under the purview of Stargate Command.

"But… Don't you have a majority in the Command Council?" Entrapta looked puzzled.

"Yes. But the United Nations is getting involved." Sam sighed. And the Alliance didn't have a majority there. Veto powers cut both ways, too.

“Oh.” Entrapta frowned. “That complicates matters. But since we know Earth’s gate address, and the Tok’ra’s, it shouldn’t be too hard to reconstruct the data we need to open gates to either location from Etheria.”

As Sam knew from experience, it was actually rather hard. But she had done it before - she knew exactly how to do it. And when she had done it, she had been using computers that had been vastly less powerful than the computers she was using with Entrapta.

Doing this wouldn’t, technically, be violating her orders. Of course, her superiours would know what Sam was doing -, and why. But they would also know that punishing her for this would not sit well with the Etherians - and that the data was crucial for the war effort.

And Sam was a little tired of political games right now. Literally.

She nodded at her friend. “Let’s get to work then.”

“Yes!”

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Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, December 18th, 1998

Standing in the back of the oval room, Catra struggled with the temptation to show how bored she was while the President - of America, not of any of the hundred or so other countries with one - signed the Alliance treaty. It was just a formality, as far as she was concerned. Anything of note had been settled a while ago, but, apparently, the United States had a specific way of doing treaties, which delayed the whole thing. One more reason why a proper kingdom was more efficient - a princess would have just formally signed the treaty at the first opportunity. According to Bow, in the past, some treaties had been signed on napkins at a Princess Prom. She had to suppress a snicker as she wondered if the napkins had food stains on them.

Showing amusement wouldn't be appropriate, after all. This was a serious occasion, at least according to Glimmer and Adora, who both stood next to the President with suitably polite smiles for the occasion. Well, Adora also was as tense as if she were on a parade ground facing inspection - or at Princess Prom - but she still took such matters a bit too seriously. At least Glimmer was more relaxed.

"...and with this signature, the United States is now a member of the Alliance against the Goauld Empire."

Also known as the Alliance. Not to be mistaken for the Princess Alliance, Catra silently added. Some poor secretary now had to remove the 'provisional' from all the paperwork already passed in the meantime. Although they probably had a second set of regulations prepared that went into effect right now - Earth countries sure loved their paperwork.

Everyone applauded, so Catra joined in. And as people started to shake hands, and cameras clicked wildly, she leaned closer to Adora and whispered: "Can we order some food now?"

"Catra!" Adra hissed. But she was smiling and not as tense any more, so Catra counted that as a win.

Besides, Earth people knew how to feed their diplomatic guests. Once the press was done taking pictures, they would have a state dinner.

*****

"...so, the Yanks managed to get their act together to sign up with the Alliance before the Tok'ra do. I guess we should be grateful to our future alien allies that the Americans finally stopped trying to take over half the Alliance leadership, but...."

"...well, it's not as if this was something that could have been delayed further, but I think waiting one more day so we could dominate the Friday evening news would have been better…"

"...and I know we're already involved in the negotiations with the Tok'ra, but that was merely a courtesy. Now that we're an official member of the Alliance, I think a few things should be revisited. Sir Watson did his best, no doubt, but since he's a Brit, I think the American perspective was a bit neglected, so…"

"...and yes, that's a really good potato soup. Reminds me of…"

"...when do you think we'll be able to buy shuttles? My kids are asking every day when I'll take them to the moon for dinner. They don't believe me when I tell them that we don't have a moon base yet, so…"

"...don't know why they are making such a fuss about the 'Mars Mission'. Who cares about that? It's just a trip riding in the back of the Etherian cab, so to speak, so…"

"...and yes, I think the United States formally joining the Alliance will simplify many organisational matters for us, though…"

Catra's ears twitched as she listened to a few conversations around them while Adora was busy explaining to some dense American that she didn't have a country of her own to rule and didn't want one either. It sounded a lot like the Princess Prom, actually - just with less gossip about relationships. But the jockeying for position, snide remarks and backstabbing she overheard were about the same.

It almost made her feel homesick. Or would, if she was a princess. She finished her third tuna sandwich - catering finally managed to get proper sizes for them after two complaints filed by her - and grabbed a fourth.

"...so, you see, I am Supreme Commander of the Alliance, so I wouldn't have the time to rule a country anyway," Adora repeated herself for the second time.

Catra shook her head and stepped closer to her lover as the - senator? Or representative? It didn't matter, anyway - frowned.

“But you are the most powerful princess, aren’t you? And an Ancient. Shouldn’t you rule?”

“That’s not how it works!” Adora exclaimed.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra spoke up before the man could keep bothering her. Why had anyone given the man access to classified intel like the Ancients anyway if he was so stupid? “I think we’re needed over there.” She pointed at the dessert buffet.

Fortunately, Adora was annoyed enough that she played along at once. “Oh, right. Terribly sorry, Senator, but duty calls.”

Catra snickered as they left - and then checked that he didn’t attempt to follow them.

“Oh, this was terrible - the man seemed to think whoever is the most powerful rules on Etheria!” Adora complained as soon as they were out of earshot. “And no matter how often I explained that that wasn’t how it worked, he didn’t listen.”

“Go thank the press for that,” Catra replied with a shrug. “And Hollywood.” She cocked her head. “And probably their own system.”

“What?”

Catra grinned. “Well, you know that the most powerful countries rule the United Nations and how much they can get away with. They probably think that’s how it works back home. Of course, if you wanted a country, I don’t think anyone could stop you from taking whichever kingdom you wanted.”

“I don’t want a country to rule!” Adora pouted at her. “I don’t want to rule anyone!”

“I know.” Catra leaned in and wrapped an am around her lover’s waist and her tail around her leg. “Something else the idiot didn’t get. But we might have to talk to Brown and Julie about setting

things straight about Etherian politics. Especially now that we are close to reopening the Stargate."

Adora nodded. "Yes. We need to make sure people on Earth know how things are done back home. Especially if they want to visit."

"If they are allowed to visit, anyway," Catra pointed out. That was something the Princess Alliance hadn't settled yet. It was a touchy question, too.

But they should discuss that in private, not in the middle of a room full of Earth politicians, diplomats and officers. And spies.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 19th, 1998

Jack O'Neill had expected this, but he still narrowed his eyes at his second-in-command. "So, the Etherians finished their own version of a D.H.D.?"

She straightened slightly but didn't otherwise react to his best 'superior's disapproval' glare. "The project was started a while ago but wasn't a priority until recently, sir."

"But once they reestablished contact with their homeworld, it became a priority." He tapped the tips of his fingers together, elbows on his desk.

"Yes, sir. It was obvious that they needed a control and a power supply unit to operate their Stargate."

He squinted - was that a smile? No. Carter wasn't amused. She was… pissed off? No. Or, at least, not at him. It was more… defiant would fit best. He was familiar with the feeling. "And you asissted Entrapta."

"In the spirit of cooperation with an important ally, sir." And now she smiled.

He sighed. “And, of course, that cooperation didn’t include access to Stargate Command’s computers.”

“Not as far as any data related to the Stargate itself was concerned, sir.”

Now that was a relief. With the power discrepancy between the Etherians and the United States - or Earth as a whole - as blatant as it was, Carter as Etrapta’s best friend could have copied the entire database in the Mountain and the brass would be forced to smile and nod in response. Though they would likely try their best to punish her in some unofficial way afterwards - that was how things were done, after all. And while Jack would still back Carter if she had done that, he really didn’t need that kind of trouble.

Of course, some unofficial disapproval-signalling would likely be done anyway, but that was something Jack was familiar with. He could easily shield Carter from that - he had done it for Daniel before, usually after a too-honest briefing of a senator or general.

Still, better check - only so he knew if he had to lie or not. “So, they didn’t get our address list and code?”

Was that surprise that he knew computer-speak? He wasn’t that old or hide-bound. But Carter nodded. “Entrapta knew the addresses used on previous missions already. With a source of power, they could, in theory, dial manually.”

It was a lot more complicated than that; even Jack knew that - Carter had explained it once. Stellar drift something, updated data, and the Etherians would want an iris as well to keep the gate secure. But it was a fig leaf to hide behind from the brass and politicians. “But they would still profit if they had our own address list?”

Carter’s lips twitched. “Yes, sir.”

“So, the US government still has a bargaining chip - or bribe - once they sort out things with the United Nations.” Good. That would keep most generals and politicians happy. And if the United

Nations managed to win that particular struggle, Jack doubted that anyone would mind if, somehow, the Etherians got the database unofficially. Quite the contrary, actually.

"I would not presume to second-guess our government, sir."

He rolled his eyes at her. "Don't overdo it, Carter."

"Yes, sir."

"So… when will the Etherians have their Stargate operational?"

"I would estimate it would take them a week to set up security and the control unit and power supply - provided that there are no issues related to Etheira's political or military needs, sir."

"You mean as long as the Etherians don't have to deal with the same problems we have," Jack summed up.

She nodded in return.

He leaned back, folding his hands over his stomach. "So, they know their gate address?"

"Yes, sir." Carter raised her chin a little.

He got the hint. Best not to ask too many questions about how exactly the Eherians had managed that without records. "Well, everything seems to be in order then, Captain."

She nodded again.

"Now, there's another task for you, Captain."

"Sir?" She cocked her head a little to the side.

"The traditional Stargate Command New Year's Party is coming up." He smiled when he caught her eyes widening. "And since I have no doubt that we'll invite the Etherians this year, I think we need your help organising it, so we don't accidentally offend anyone." And Daniel's, but he would consider that a treat.

“Yes, sir.”

She narrowed her eyes at him, and his smile grew wider. Yes, officially, everything was fine, but unofficially, some punishment was still merited for doing this behind his back instead of telling him.

And, more importantly, for getting caught by him.

*****

Going Home Part 2

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, December 27th, 1998

There was the Stargate. It was still closed - well, the iris was closed, and the gate was inactive - but that wouldn't be the case for much longer. Soon, the gate would be dialling - and they would be able to return to Etheria. To their friends. To their home.

Adora couldn't wait. And her friends couldn't wait either. Glimmer was alternating between staring at the gate as if she wanted to teleport through it right away and glaring at the technicians operating the gate as if that would make them divert from their schedule. Bow and Entrapta were standing before a screen carried by Emily, giving Micah and Castaspella some unneeded advice - just today, they had already checked the gate's setup at least three times. Hordak was standing to the side and behind Entrapta, outside the angle where the camera would pick him up, but he was looking at the gate as well when he thought no one was paying attention. And Catra was…

…perched on a computer console as if it was a wall and doing her best to fake being bored.

She was trying too hard. Adora shook her head with a smile and wandered over. "Hey."

Catra turned her head to look at her. "That's my line."

"It'll open soon," Adora said, nodding towards the gate.

"I know." Catra cocked her head, then sniffed the air. "Someone's got a tuna sandwich."

"And it's theirs," Adora told her.

"I know." Catra rolled her eyes. "I'm just making small talk."

“Ah.” Adora nodded. “So, I don’t need t make a run to the cantine and get another one?”

Her lover snorted. “If I wanted one, I’d go myself. Besides, we have a feast waiting for us in the palace.”

“And you packed a crate full of the cans,” Adora added.

“As trade goods.” Catra scoffed. “People will pay anything I ask for a taste of Earth. I’ll rake in the cash! It’ll be even better than the time we found that Alliance ration on the training ground.”

“Ah, yes.” They had been able to trade for a dozen of the good Horde rations. But they wouldn’t have done that if they had known how good it was. Still… “You could have picked any kind of food you wanted. But you picked tuna.”

Catra stuck her tongue out at her. “I wanted something that was cheap and that I liked. Just in case I have to demonstrate that it’s safe.”

“Of course.” Adora grinned at her. She would be surprised if Catra sold half the cans - it wasn’t as if she needed money. If they needed anything, they could just ask Glimmer.

“Clear the gate area!”

It was starting! Adora turned around while Catra jumped down from the console, and both of them hurried to the waiting area in front of the gate. They would be home soon!

Their friends joined them as well. Even Emily seemed to walk more quickly as she followed Entrapta.

And there was Jack, walking over to them. “Excited?”

Catra snorted, but Adora nodded.

“Do you expect us to get shot?” Glimmer asked, looking pointedly at the rifle at his side. “In Bright Moon?”

“What? Oh, no. But regulations are regulations. No unarmed gate travel during wartime! Never know when you might end up somewhere else.” Jack grinned as the rest of SG-1 formed up next to him.

“Like on Etheria,” Entrapta chimed in. “Though the chance that there’s a malfunction is very low, in my estimate.”

“And we’ll test the gate with a bot first,” Bow said.

Emily took a step back, and Entrapta beamed at her. “Not you, of course! We’ve got a spy bot for that!”

The bot - a dumb bot, Entrapta had reassured them - was standing in front of the gate ramp already.

“Let’s get on with it,” Catra muttered.

As if the technician - Sergeant Siler - had been waiting for her comment, the activation sequence started. Adora took a deep breath as the iris opened, the gate ring spun and the chevrons became locked in. One… two… three…

Soon, all seven were locked in, and the gate formed.

“Go, Spy-Twelve!” Entrapta commanded, and the bot walked up the ramp, then disappeared through the gate.

Everyone turned to look at the screen Emily was still carrying. Adora could see the bot walking down the ramp their friends had erected for the gate.

“It looks good… running a diagnosis… yes. No detectable structural changes,” Entrapta announced.

“I assume that means we’re good to go,” Catra said.

Adora nodded - and stepped onto the ramp. It was time to go home.

A few quick steps took her right to the gate. This was… just another gate trip, she reminded herself as she took a deep breath. She had gone through Stargates many times by now.

But it was also a return home. Smiling, she walked into the gate.

A familiar but still disorienting moment later, she blinked - she was outside, in the sunlight - oh, the air smelt like…

“Dad!”

“Glimmer!”

Adora stepped to the side when Glimmer charged down the ramp, straight into Micah’s arms.

All their friends were there! She had known that - they had been talking to them every day to help set up the gate - but seeing them was different. There was Netossa, Spinnerella, Mermista with Sea Hawk, Perfuma and Scorpia, and…

“Adora!” A shadow fell on her.

Yes! Swift Wind landed in front of her, right on the ramp.

“I missed you so much!” he told her.

“I missed you too,” she replied as she buried her face into the side of his neck.

“Watch the wings!” Adora heard Catra cry out.

She felt the wings flap - once; Swift Wind didn’t lift off - but she was busy hugging him.

“Whoa!” That was Bow. But the ramp was wide enough for him to go around Swift Wind.

“Our sacred bond was strained but not broken even though you travelled to the ends of the universe!”

“We didn’t even leave the Galaxy!” Catra commented.

“Wildcat!”

“Hey, ScoOOF! Lemme go!”

“No!”

“Hello!”

Adora released Swift Wind and looked around. It seemed everyone had decided to step onto the ramp - which wasn’t bare metal, as in Stargate Command, but made from stone inlaid with crystal, she noticed. Bow was hugging his Dads, Catra was trying - and failing - to squirm out of Scorpia’s arms, Perfuma was beaming and hanging out flower necklaces to everyone, Glimmer and Micah were still hugging, and…

…everyone needed to leave the ramp since Entrapta had just arrived, followed by Hordak, which meant Emily would be next.

“Whoa!”

“Watch out!”

The ramp definitely wasn’t big enough for everyone and Emily.

“Mount up!” Swift Wind called out as he stepped off the ramp - and hovered in place.

Adora slid on his back, and he took off.

“Hey!” Catra called after her. “Let me go, Scorpia!”

“No!”

“I missed you so much,” Swift Wind repeated himself as they cleared the tops of the trees surrounding the gate.

Adora looked down. The Stargate had been placed on the edge of the Whispering Wood - in Bright Moon’s territory but close enough

to the actual woods that there were no villages nearby. And it was mounted in a frame that would allow it to be flipped and lowered into the ground. Not quite an iris, but it would do.

"We can't fly off yet," she told her friend. "I need to greet everyone first." And introduce - well, reintroduce - SG-1.

"I haven't seen you in months!" Swift Wind complained. But he banked and turned around, then started to descend in wide circles.

"We'll fly after that," she reassured him as she spotted SG-1 arriving through the gate.

"I'll hold you to that!"

"You know, millions of little girls would gleefully kill us all to take your place," Jack told her as soon as Swift Wind touched down next to the ramp.

"I don't let just anyone ride me!" Swift Wind replied indignantly.

Adora patted his flank before dismounting. She shouldn't have left for so long. Then she got to hug all her friends. Even if they didn't want to be hugged.

"Everyone who hasn't met them yet: This is SG-1. Colonel Jack O'Neill, Captain Samantha Carter, Dr Daniel Jackson and Teal'c," Glimmer announced after she finally pulled back from her dad. "They're our friends and allies."

"And lab and science buddies!" Entrapta added with a beaming smile. "Sam and I built a spacelab! We can do experiments there that would be too dangerous for Earth!"

"Ah." Sea Hawk nodded. "They probably have no empty lots left on a planet with six billion people and vast oceans."

"Actually, we have a lot of deserts," Daniel said. "The population is mostly concentrated in several areas."

“They have cities that have millions of people,” Catra added. “And more metal and factories than the Fright Zone had.”

“Wow!” Scorpia blinked.

“Really? Do you need help with restoring nature there as well?” Perfuma asked. “I’ve learned a lot dealing with the aftermath of the war in the Scorpio Kingdom.”

“Ah, we still need those cities. You know, for living in them, working in them…” Jack said with a fake smile - Adora could tell. “Please don’t turn them into plants.”

“Oh, but I can grow living buildings!” Perfuma perked up. “A city in harmony with nature.”

Jack stared at her.

Sam came to his rescue. “We have laws about introducing new species to an area - in the past, such things often caused small disasters. Any such project would require careful and extensive planning and experiments - and the consent of the local authorities.”

“Well, of course, but…”

Swift Wind stamped the ground. “Let’s go flying!”

Adora looked at her friends. At Catra.

Her lover snorted. “Go fly, or he’ll never shut up.”

Swift Wind snorted at her before turning to Adora. “You heard her. Let’s fly!”

She wanted to, but…

“Just be back in an hour or two for the meeting,” Glimmer told her. “We’ve got this handled.”

Well, with her friends' blessings… Adora beamed at them, then quickly climbed on Swift Wind's back.

"I have so much to tell you!" he gushed as they soared up, flying high above the ground. "We've been making great inroads in freeing my people from slavery on Etheria! Some kingdoms are still resisting, but it's just a question of time. But there was that one princess…"

As he talked, Adora leaned back and smiled, looking at the land below, Bright Moon in the distance, the Whispering Woods…

She was finally home again.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, December 27th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter watched as the winged unicorn - the alicorn, a girl's voice in her head insisted - took off and climbed up. Yes, millions of little girls would indeed love to be in Adora's place. And many boys, women and men as well. Maybe even including one Samantha Carter, but that was neither here nor there.

"Well, nothing's better proof that you're not in Kansas any more than seeing a princess ride a flying horse," the Colonel commented.

"There's only one flying horse on Etheria," Catra commented.

"But one is enough. He's rather… memorable, after all," he retorted.

"And pushy. And needy." Catra snorted.

"Takes one to know one," Glimmer said.

Catra seemed to ignore her, shading her eyes as she looked at the horse and rider in the sky. "Well, they'll be a while."

“Alright, I’ve told Stargate Command that we arrived safely,” the Colonel said. A moment later, the gate went inactive.

“Lower the gate!” Someone - Netossa, Sam remembered the princess’s name - called out, and the gate started to tilt back, slowly being lowered into a ready-made pit.

“We have to build a proper iris,” Entrapta commented as she watched. “And better defences.”

Sam nodded. They had gone over this, after all.

“And speaking of defences…” The Colonel looked around. “This is a little open, isn’t it?”

“Fewer opportunities for anyone to hide,” Netossa told him. “And we have it under guard.”

Sam could see bots and soldiers forming a perimeter.

“And if everything else fails, there’s a frigate in stationary orbit above us, ready to bombard the entire area,” the princess added, looking directly at the Colonel.

“That’s going to leave a crater,” he commented. He glanced up, Sam noted, as did she, even though she didn’t think she’d be able to spot the frigate at this distance without a telescope.

“As would using a bomb.” The princess shrugged. “It’s just temporary anyway - we’ll build a gatehouse here once Entrapta finishes the control and power supply unit.” She grinned. “More guards, bots and automated defences, as well as a bunch of sorceresses from Mystacore. No one’s going to get through here.”

Netossa was one of the most experienced princesses, together with her wife, Sam reminded herself.

“We’ll get right on that!” Entrapta said. “After I’ve checked in with the bots. Some of them will need special maintenance and upgrades.”

“Horde-trained technicians should be perfectly able to maintain and repair any bot produced so far,” Hordak commented.

Entrapta pouted at him. “But no one’s perfect, so I should be checking their work.”

Emily beeped in agreement.

Sam smiled - her friend was correct, but that wasn’t the only or even main reason Entrapta wanted to check the bots. They were her friends. Or family, in a way. “We need to reassess them anyway, to incorporate them into the gate defences,” she said.

“Yes!” Entrapta agreed, nodding repeatedly. “Can’t skimp here - this is the gate to Etheria.” She cocked her head. “It’s too bad we didn’t get the Tok’ra’s tunnelling technology yet - we could prepare a complete underground base in a day!”

Which would be safer than a Stargate placed in a base above ground. Both against infiltrators/invasions as well as attacks from the outside. Sooner or later, they’d move the gate on Etheria underground; Sam was sure of that. The advantages were just too great.

But not today.

“You mentioned their tunnelling technology,” Netossa said, nodding. “But an underground base also means that if someone took it and had access to that technology, they could easily use it to move from the gate undetected.”

“Only if they manage to take the gate without raising an alert,” Spinnerella objected.

“And you can detect the tunnels using seismic sensors,” Sam pointed out. “Or magic.”

The princess nodded, but with a frown. “That’ll make the whole base more expensive than planned.”

“That’s the case with most projects,” King Micah chimed in with a smile. “We’ll shoulder the costs anyway - this is too important.”

Seeing how he was beaming at Glimmer, Sam couldn’t help feeling that the king was probably as concerned about the fact that the Stargate would allow his daughter to return home whenever she wanted as he was about the security issues. She wasn’t Daniel, but such a view seemed quite typical for the Etherians.

“Anyway,” King Micah continued, “Let’s move to the palace now. We have a lot to discuss, but we should get comfortable first. We’ve prepared a small meal as well, in case you’re hungry.” He grinned. “You’ve travelled a long way, after all.”

“Oh! Do you have tiny food prepared?” Entrapta leaned forward.

“Of course!”

“Yes!” Sam’s friend beamed at him, then grabbed Hordak’s arm before turning to Sam. “Let’s go!”

“We also have normal-sized food,” the king added with a chuckle.

“Oh! I’ve missed homemade food!” Glimmer eyed the spire of Brightmoon, visible in the distance, as if she wanted to teleport ahead, Sam noticed.

She probably could, Sam knew. They were on a planet full of magic, she reminded herself. Etheria might only have a population of fifty million, but between the sorceresses of Mystacore and the various princesses, they would have the most magically active individuals of any planet in the sector.

She wouldn’t even think of them as ‘magic-users’. The Colonel wouldn’t stop cracking Dungeons and Dragons jokes for a long time.

“Let’s go then. We’ve prepared skiffs for the trip.” King Micah gestured towards several of the flying vehicles - hovering vehicles,

Sam corrected herself; they couldn't fly very high - in the background.

For a change, the Colonel simply agreed without making a snarky comment. It was almost magical.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 27th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Bright Moon was the same as always, Catra thought as their skiffs entered the main gate. OK, usually, the people didn't line up to cheer whenever Glimmer returned home, but she had been away for months, so that was to be expected.

But the city itself looked the same. Same buildings, same streets. No new construction - well, she could see a handyman waving from a half-dismantled balcony, but that looked more like maintenance. And the people looked the same as well. Well-fed and happy. Happier than usual, but that was likely because they were focusing on Glimmer instead of Catra.

And while it wasn't really home - that was Adora - and she knew that the people still resented her, and with good reasons, it still was… nice to be back. Sort of.

"It's safe."

She turned her head to frown at Scorpia. "Of course, it's safe. It's Bright Moon. Even we never managed to take it." Though they had come close to cracking the shield protecting it. A small reminder that Scorpia had been with her then and there might also do some good - Catra didn't want to get her ribs cracked by another too-powerful hug. It was also undignified; she could already hear O'Neill's jokes.

Her friend kept beaming at her, though. And her pincer twitched a little. "Yes. And it would take an army to crack its defences."

"Or a small fleet in orbit," Catra pointed out. "Maybe a squadron."

“Do you have to talk about how to destroy the city?” Perfuma, sitting next to Scorpia, leaned forward and turned her head to pout at both of them. “You’re finally back! That’s a time for celebration, not… gloomy things!”

“I’m just pointing out that Bright Moon is safe from ground assaults, but we can’t get complacent since now there’s also an orbital threat to worry about,” Catra retorted.

“But we have a fleet in orbit. A fleet and a half - or one-third, actually, I think,” Perfuma said.

But it wasn’t Bright Moon’s fleet. Catra didn’t say that out loud. The Horde remnants were their allies - WrongHordak was a close friend, as far as Catra could tell. But as the recent attack had proven, there were more clones out there. And she had no idea what the rest of Second Fleet thought. Or if First Fleet’s remains were still focused on Hordak.

She couldn’t help glancing up. Yes, an orbital bombardment would probably raze Bright Moon. Sure, the shield would hold a long time, but they had nothing to shoot back.

She snorted. In a way, Bright Moon’s situation wasn’t that different from the United States’s.

“Don’t worry, Wildcat! Adora will be back soon!”

Catra snorted again. Her friend had misread her mood. “I know,” she said, leaning back and watching the palace gates as they approached.

“I bet!” Scorpia was beaming at her. As was Perfuma. Their smiles looked eerily similar, Catra noticed.

“So…” Perfuma looked at the skiff ahead of them, where SG-1 was riding with Glimmer and Micah. “Did you make more friends on Earth?”

Catra refrained from frowning. She should have expected that question from Perfuma. Though Scorpia looked like she wanted to know as well. And Catra couldn't tell if Scorpia would be happy or jealous if they had more close friends. Or both. So she shrugged. "We mainly worked with SG-1. And spent time with them," she added when Perfuma opened her mouth.

"Ah." Scorpia nodded.

"What about the Earth leaders?" Perfuma asked.

"We had some dinners with them, lots of meetings…" Catra shrugged again. "But things are different there. Their leaders are all much older, and… they don't really do things like we do."

"What do you mean?" Scorpia looked puzzled.

They hadn't gone over that before, had they? Not in-depth, at least. Daniel would explain it better, but Catra would still give it a shot. "Their leaders just lead their countries. That's all they do. And they don't, ah, hang out with us. SG-1 does."

"Ah." Scorpia nodded again.

Perfuma frowned. "That doesn't seem very friendly."

"It's not how they do things. They're different. Though some of their meetings are like the Princess Prom, just without dancing and less flirting." She grinned.

"They sound very serious," Perfuma remarked. "Unlike Colonel O'Neill."

"Oh, yes." Catra nodded.

"So, you didn't meet any new close friends?" Scorpia asked.

Catra shook her head. "Entrapta met a Tok'ra scientist, Anise, and her host, Freya, and they and Sam seem close," she said. "But we haven't really had the opportunity to meet many Earth people

outside meetings and such, except for SG-1. Though maybe we'll meet more people at the Stargate Command New Year's Party."

"Oh? A party?" Scorpia smiled.

"Great! When is it? After you restored the Stargate, right?" Perfuma leaned forward with an eager expression. A very eager expression. "What gifts should we bring? What's the dress code? Do they have a dress code?"

Catra blinked. Perfuma expected to attend the party, she realised. Although… technically, the invitation O'Neill had passed on hadn't really specified who was invited and who was not. He had just told them that they were invited. And since they were representing the Princess Alliance on Earth…

Catra grinned widely. "Well, I have to ask them about gifts. I know they have a custom of exchanging gifts on Christmas, but that's within a family and already past. And we didn't ask about a dress code either."

Oh, she couldn't wait to drop this on O'Neill!

*****

The palace still looks like someone stole it straight from a Disney movie, Jack O'Neill thought as they stepped through the gate. Clean, shining marble, wide hallways, tall - very tall - ceilings. "Anytime now, they'll break out in a song," he muttered as he looked at the lined-up guards presenting their spears.

"What did you say?" Daniel asked. He, of course, was looking around with a big smile on his face as if he was seeing everything for the first time.

"Nothing," Jack replied. "Just glad to see the palace's still standing. What with the battle against Horde fleets and all, you know?"

Daniel's face fell, making Jack feel guilty. A little, at least. "Ah, yes. But it was just a small, ah, detachment, right? No real threat to Etheria. And it never came close to the planet." And he was smiling at Jack again. "In any case, it's great to be back! This is such a fascinating culture! Unlike most planets we've visited, it's not clearly derived from an ancient Earth culture!"

"Just don't treat the population as some exhibit or specimen," Jack told him.

"I would never!" Daniel frowned at him.

Jack grinned, but he had been only half-joking. Daniel could be a little too enthusiastic sometimes. Of course, he was a good friend of Glimmer and the others, and, seeing how the people had been cheering at their queen's return, that should keep him out of trouble, but a little reminder never hurt.

Oh - the King was walking towards him. It looked like he had finally been able to pry himself out of the arms of his daughter. Jack once again felt guilty for his thought - the man hadn't seen Glimmer for months, so it was only understandable that he'd react like that. Even as a king.

"We've prepared your usual quarters," King Micah told them with a smile.

"Our 'usual quarters'? We've come up in the world!" Jack said, grinning at him.

"Jack!" Daniel gasped next to him.

But the King laughed. "Well, we expect you to visit very often, now that we'll soon have an easy way to travel to Earth and back."

The Chair Force jokes would probably never end if that got out. Once that got out. Jack nodded anyway. Who cared what the crayon eaters thought? "Thank you. Although I expect the Alliance

will send a diplomatic delegation soon enough." As soon as the Etherians accepted the request, actually.

"Of course. Although, as I understand, you are planning to build an embassy in the future."

"Yes, Dad," Glimmer cut in. "As we told you. But we can sort this out in the meeting later."

Jack had seen younger officers do similar things when they felt their older, more experienced subordinates were undercutting them, but judging by the way Gimmer grabbed her father's arm, it was probably more that the girl wanted to have her father to herself instead of dealing with their guests.

"Yes." Jack nodded. "I think I still know the way."

"Don't worry - I'll guide you there." Catra had somehow snuck up on them. And the way she was grinning widely…

Jack narrowed his eyes at her. "You're volunteering?"

She got the joke and laughed. "Yes. Because a question came up." She pointed at the huge Scorpion-woman and the plant princess behind her. "Scorpia and Perfuma want to know if there's a dress code at the New Year's Party and what gifts they should bring."

Jack forced himself to keep smiling as Catra's grin grew even wider. They also wanted to attend the party? He noticed that others were paying attention as well - all of the princesses? Oh, for crying out loud!

"The New Year's Party?" King Micah asked. Not him too!

"Yes," Glimmer said. "It's held by Stargate Command. And Jack was nice enough to invite us."

"It's not a big affair," Jack quickly explained. "Since many in Stargate Command have to work on the holidays - we have to keep the lights going and watch the Stargate, you know? - and

can’t travel to meet friends and family, we generally hold a small party for them.” And for those who had no family, were estranged from them or couldn’t visit them because they were held prisoners by the Goa’uld. Which accounted for all or, now that Carter and her father had reconciled, most of SG-1.

“That sounds wonderful!” King Micah beamed at him.

“Yes!” Scorpia nodded far too enthusiastically. “Like the parties we threw in the Horde, only with good food and friends, instead of rations and subordinates.”

“Yeah, right, exactly,” Jack’s smile grew a few more teeth as he looked at the grinning Catra.

“So, what’s the dress code?” Perfuma the plant princess asked with wide eyes and a wider smile.

“Well…” They didn’t have one, actually, as far as Jack knew - soldiers and their spouses were expected to know to dress appropriately. “Nothing too fancy,” he said. Oh! He smiled. “But I’m no the best person to ask about this - Captain Carter here is actually helping with organising it, so she can answer all your questions!” He gestured at his subordinate, whose look of shock was quickly turning into a glare aimed at him.

“Sam!”

“I didn’t know that you were organising the party!”

“Oh, you are? Can we help? I wanted to see if we could build a mix-bot, like in that movie we saw!” Entrapta beamed at Carter.

Who, Jack noted, blinked, then slowly smiled. “Oh, I am sure that can be arranged.”

Maybe dumping that on my second-in-command hadn’t been a good idea, Jack thought and suppressed the urge to wince as the princesses and other royalty gathered around Carter. He just knew

that Hammond and the other generals would blame him for turning their office party into a high-profile event…

*****

Above Bright Moon, Etheria, December 27th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"I've missed this," Adora said, looking down at the fields surrounding Bright Moon from Swift Wind's back. They were high enough so she could see most of the Whispering Woods - which reminded her that she had to visit Madame Razz once she had the time. She could also see the farm they had visited with Jack and someone moving over the fields there, but she couldn't tell who it was.

"...and I've had to personally free more horses since the princess was dragging her feet."

What did he say? "You invaded a kingdom?" Adora asked.

"Micah said it wasn't an invasion," her friend said as he banked to avoid a small cloud.

"But you went into another kingdom and…" She couldn't say 'stole'; Swift Wind didn't consider horses as property. "...freed horses?"

"Yes. They were keeping them leashed to carts and ploughs, can you imagine?" Swift Wind turned his head to look at her with a - for him - shocked expression. "It was slavery, plain and simple!"

So he *had* raided another kingdom. Probably more than one. "And where did you take the horses?" He wouldn't just release them, would he? They would just be recaptured, wouldn't they?

"Micah had them relocated to pastures in Bright Moon."

That was… concerning, actually. "Ah, OK," she said. "How did you get them to Bright Moon?" He couldn't carry them away after all -

well, maybe he could carry a pony if someone helped and tied it to his back, but…

"I led them," Swift Wind said matter-of-factly. "I flew ahead, and they followed. Although I had to convince the stallion that I knew what I was doing."

Adora narrowed her eyes. He was staring at the ground a bit too attentively as he said that and avoided looking at her. Still, it was probably a minor thing, even if he thought it was important. There was something else that was bugging her more. "So, you're working with Micah on this?"

"I lead the freed slaves to him, and he sends them to pastures."

Adora suppressed a sigh. She had to talk to Micah about this. As much as she loved Swift Wind, you couldn't just go and raid other kingdoms. And sooner or later, someone would stop Swift Wind. He was magical and smart, but, ultimately, he was a flying horse, not a princess. Well, he was probably as powerful as some princesses she had heard of, but if he were to fight any of Adora's friends, she'd bet on them, not him. He must have gotten lucky so far.

Or, she realised with a gasp, the other kingdoms thought he was acting on She-Ra's orders! Swift Wind was her magical steed, after all. And her friend.

Oh, no! What if Micah thought the same? They had never talked about what Swift Wind was doing, had they? She really needed to talk to Micah. And the others.

She took a last look at the land below her, and the mountains, woods and glittering sea in the far distance, then sighed and patted Swift Wind's neck. "We need to land."

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 27th, 1998 (Earth Time)

“We’ve been invading other kingdoms?”

Adora winced a little at the volume of Glimmer’s… well, it was technically a question. It was a good thing that they were in her living room with the doors closed or the entire palace probably would have heard her.

“It’s not an invasion,” Micah said.

“I’d say it’s a raid,” Catra commented from the couch. She was grinning - apparently, she thought this was hilarious. “Sneaking over the border and stealing livestock.”

“Invasion, raid - it doesn’t matter! We’re attacking other countries - condoning raids by Swift Wind,” Glimmer added with a glare aimed at Micah before he could correct her again.

He closed his mouth and looked a little sheepish.

“You’ve gone full bandit queen!” Catra laughed. “Or is that pirate queen? We have to ask Mermista if you can give letters of marque to horses.”

“Letters of marque?” Micah asked.

He hadn’t seen the Earth pirate movies, Adora reminded herself as Bow explained the term. Apparently, Salineas didn’t issue such letters but formally commissioned the ships that raided Horde transports. Which worked out the same, as far as Adora could tell.

“Whatever!” Glimmer paced in front of them, gesticulating. “This is a diplomatic crisis!” She turned to glare at Micah again. “Why didn’t you stop him?”

“Ah…” Micah smiled weakly. “Technically, what he does outside our borders - or the borders of our allies - isn’t a concern of ours?”

“That…” Glimmer shook her head. “This has to stop!”

"Yes," Catra agreed, chuckling still. "You're going to run out of pastures to put horses on if this continues. And all the manure the herds must produce…" She grinned at the glare sent her way.

"It's not funny!"

Adora had to agree with Glimmer.

Catra, of course, disagreed. With a shrug, she said: "It kind of is. Everyone must think that you're backing this."

"We compensate the owners for the loss," Micah said.

"Everyone thinks we are behind this!" Glimmer snapped. "And the Alliance! Why hasn't anyone stopped him?"

"Well…" Micah looked at Adora.

Oh, no! "Because everyone thinks he's doing it for me," Adora said, sighing. "Or that if they stop him, I'll get angry at them."

Micah nodded, confirming her fears.

"Well, tell him to stop. At least he's only been hitting the smaller kingdoms," Catra said, looking at the map on the table where all the raids had been marked. "None of them are members of the Princess Alliance. And they're too weak to matter militarily."

"But there are quite a few of them," Bow pointed out.

"Yes," Glimmer agreed. "And that is going to be a problem now that we have to decide how to handle the Stargate on Etheria."

Adora winced. She hadn't even thought of that.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, December 27th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Alright… the converter is connected! Wanna test it now?"

Samantha Carter nodded at Entrapta's question. "Yes." She took a step back from the crystal array that would provide the magic power to be converted. Not that she expected or feared that the array would explode, but it was the unexpected disaster that tended to kill you. "Ready?" She glanced at her friend.

Entratpa had also stepped back. "Yes!"

"Powering up." Sam pressed the main power button. The array started to hum, and the various lights on the control panel lit up, all indicators showing green. Then the main unit started to glow softly, red hues slowly turning brighter as the power increased.

"Converter's working!" Entrapta announced. "Power outflow… steady. Steady. Capacitors charging up."

Sam raised her head and looked at the capacitors. Those were an Earth design, familiar but also looking strangely out of place next to both the Stargate and the Etherian gear.

But they worked, and that was what counted. Sam watched as the charging indicators changed until they lit up green - the power necessary to run the gate had been stored in them. She let out a soft sigh - the first step to get the Stargate on Etheria operational had been achieved. The easiest step, too - but they were ahead of schedule.

Of course, they were ahead of schedule because Sam had used the excuse of having to work on the gate to escape the gaggle of princesses asking about the New Year's Party; the original schedule would have had them start working on the gate tomorrow.

Sam felt a little guilty for asking Entrapta to start their work immediately instead of letting her reconnect with her friends - especially since Sam had known that Entrapta would agree. On the other hand, her friend loved the work, and establishing the Stargate was of crucial importance. Not the least since SG-1 was stuck here as well until the gate was active.

A fact that Sam had been counting on to get out from wasting time on the New Year's Party assignment that the Colonel had saddled her with. She was a scientist, not a party planner! And her work on the gate control unit was much more important than preparing an oversized office party.

But now the office party was set to become a major diplomatic event, with the top leaders of the Princess Alliance all going to attend. Sam was torn between a little satisfaction that the Colonel's punishment had backfired on him and dread that she would have to actually spend quite the effort on planning the party, probably having to rope Daniel into it as well.

She shook her head as the array powered down, then set the capacitors to slowly release their charge.

"So, do you think we'll get a mixing bot ready in time for the party? If we continue to finish ahead of schedule, I think we'll have enough time, right?"

Apparently, Sam couldn't even escape the party planning here. She forced herself to smile - it wasn't Entrapta's fault that Sam had been assigned to this farce. It was the Colonel's fault. And just because she had done what she knew the Colonel would have done himself if he had known - doing it without his knowledge had only served to help protect him!

But her friend had asked a question. "Yes, I think we'll be able to finish the bot - at least the construction part," she said. They could reuse the schematics and parts from one of Entrapta's servant bots. If they could serve tea, they could pour any other liquid as well. "But we will have to see how we can program it with the necessary recipes." And they'd have to calibrate the sensors so it could check that the liquids it would be mixing were of the correct type - it would have to be refilled during the party, and Sam wasn't keen on supervising that kind of work during a party, so it was best if it didn't have to rely on a competent operator. Alcohol and competency didn't tend to mix well in her experience.

“Oh, right. I’ll have to ask my cook and Glimmer’s cooks about their recipes. And the others as well! Although probably not the former Horde cooks - I don’t know if their stills are still active.”

Oh. Sam hadn’t even considered using a bot to make Etherian cocktails. If only because importing the ingredients from Etheria without permission would probably violate not just regulations but the law. She winced. “That might be a bit complicated.”

“Oh?”

Sighing once more, Sam started to explain.

It was a good thing they were alone here. If her peers in the scientific community could see her now, dealing with the legality of a booze-producing bot instead of advancing physics, her reputation might never recover.

*****

Going Home Part 3

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 27th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"...we can't just let anyone use the Stargate! It's a crucial resource for the war against the Goa'uld!"

Catra nodded in agreement with Glimmer's argument, then caught herself. Just because Sparkles was correct didn't mean that Catra had to publicly acknowledge it.

"But as with Earth's Stargate, the gate doesn't belong to a single kingdom or faction but to the entire planet," Adora said. "We can't just take it for ourselves."

Catra sighed as Adora and Glimmer stared at each other. Her lover, well… she wasn't exactly wrong, but they were at war.

"We're at war. We can't let anyone else take it," Glimmer shot back. "It's not about owning the gate - but we have to control it."

"And why should the gate belong to everyone?" Mermista frowned. "The Princess Alliance is the reason the other kingdoms still exist. We fought; they didn't do anything. If we hadn't beaten Horde Prime, he would have destroyed Etheria." She scoffed. "I don't see why we should let people who didn't care enough to fight the Horde have a say about who gets to use the gate. Or control it," she added with an eye-roll.

Catra narrowed her eyes. If not for *Adora*, Etheria would have been destroyed. Twice over. By Horde Prime and the Heart of Etheria.

Adora shook her head. "But that doesn't give us the right to rule Etheria. We are better than that!"

"And we kind of set an example when we insisted on approaching Earth instead of the USA," Bow said. "Even though the USA was the only country fighting the Goa'uld."

Glimmer scoffed. “That’s not the same! They kept the Stargate and the entire war a secret!”

Catra nodded. That had been very short-sighted of them. But… it still was a precedent. Sort of.

“But we have to live up to our example,” Perfuma said. “How can people trust us if we don’t act according to our own ideals?”

Scorpia, no surprise, nodded in support of her. “Yeah. Just because we’re more powerful than the other kingdoms doesn’t mean we should just push them around, you know?” She shrugged her armoured shoulders and spread her pincers.

Catra glanced at Adora. Her lover was wincing - no doubt thinking about Swift Wind’s campaign to ‘free’ all horses.

“But we shouldn’t let them push us around either,” Glimmer retorted. “Besides, someone has to control the Stargate, and the Princess Alliance is the obvious choice. We’re the biggest organisation on Etheria.”

“And you’re composed of the most powerful kingdoms,” Catra pointed out. “Earth has the ‘United Nations’, but they are controlled by their most powerful countries.”

Adora frowned at her, but she was just telling the truth. Earth was controlled by its most powerful countries. Of course, her lover didn’t accept that. “That doesn’t mean we have to follow their example,” Adora insisted.

“But as Glimmer said: we can’t just let anyone use the gate. Not during a war - it’s our biggest weakness,” Netossa said. “We need to control the Stargate as much as we need to control Etheria’s orbit. Just imagine what would happen if the Goa’uld manage to take control of a kingdom!”

Adora sighed but then nodded - grudgingly; Catra could tell. “Yes, that’s clear. We need to control who travels through the Stargate.

But we can't just take it. And once the war's won, we need to let everyone use it."

"Within reason," Glimmer replied. "We'll need an organisation like Stargate Command. But only once the war's over. Until then, the Princess Alliance can and should control the Stargate. It's a crucial resource for the war and a glaring weakness."

"And if anyone wants to have a say about the gate, they can join us," Spinnerella said. "If they aren't willing to fight the Goa'uld, they shouldn't be allowed to use the Stargate."

Catra nodded in agreement. "That sounds fair." She ignored the glances from Frosta and Mermista.

"Forcing people to fight a war to use the Stargate seems not very fair," Perfuma commented.

"We're not taking anything away from them - we discovered the Stargate. We defend Etheria from the Goa'uld. They can continue living their lives as before, but if they want to use the Stargate - in wartime - they need to follow our rules," Glimmer said. "That's not hypocrisy; that's just common sense."

"And what do we do if they want to use the Stargate to travel to Earth?" Bow asked. "And what do we do if Earth countries want to send people to us?"

"Countries that are in the Alliance - or those who aren't," Catra added.

"Ah…" Adora closed her mouth.

And Glimmer frowned again. But it was a good question. And now that everyone in the Alliance was present, it was time to answer it.

Or, as was more likely, in Catra's opinion, discuss and debate without deciding it. That part of the United Nations Etheria had

down pat. Sometimes, she wished She-Ra was the ruler of Etheria.

*****

"You know, Jack, Sam's not going to be happy with you."

Jack O'Neill knew that. Very well. He had known she wouldn't be happy before he had thrown her to the wolves - figuratively, not literally. Here on a planet with talking - and flying, mustn't forget the flying - magical horses, it was better to clarify that. But appearances had to be upheld. So he leaned back in the best armchair in their quarters (and that meant something in Bright Moon's palace) and said: "She managed to easily handle the situation, so I don't really think she has any reason to complain."

"She claimed she had urgent work on the gate to do," Daniel retorted with a frown. "I don't recall hearing about such work in the briefing."

"Carter's the gate expert." Jack shrugged. It had been a bit of a copout, but it got the raving party princesses off her back. Whatever works was the rule for a reason.

Daniel sighed with a put-on expression Jack was very familiar with. "She was fleeing the palace, Jack!"

"I wouldn't say 'fleeing'," Jack objected with a slight grin - it had been amusing, after all.

"The wise warrior withdraws in the face of overwhelming odds to offer battle again once the situation is more favourable. Captain Carter is wise indeed."

"Thank you, Teal'c," Jack commented.

"I still don't understand why you assigned her to the party preparations," Daniel complained. "I mean, back then, this wasn't a diplomatic event - just the usual party."

“With the Etherians attending,” Jack pointed out.

“Those who had spent months on Earth already and were, therefore, at least somewhat familiar with our customs, and it was - or should be - a quite controllable environment.” Daniel shook his head. “And don’t you always say that we should focus on the important parts of our job and not waste time on the unimportant bits?”

That was about paperwork. And some paperwork was actually important.

“Indeed. It is puzzling why you would assign this task to Captain Carter. She is a fierce warrior and an outstanding scientist, but she has never struck me as a, as the correct term is, I believe, ‘party animal’.”

They were ganging up on him! Jack looked at his friends. Daniel was frowning, and Teal’c was as inscrutable as ever, but both met his eyes. They wouldn’t drop this.

He sighed. He could make up something about Carter needing to unwind and relax more, but he didn’t think that would fool them. Time to come clean - as long as Carter wasn’t here, at least. “It’s punishment detail.” At least for Carter. Others would thrive there.

“Punishment detail?” Daniel blinked. “But… why?”

Teal’C nodded. He got it.

“A small reminder that I’m the leader of this team,” Jack explained. “If anyone has to take the heat for doing the right thing without orders, or against orders, it’s going to be me. Not you lot.”

Daniel opened his mouth, closed it again without saying anything and made a half-hearted gasp. “Oh. But what did she do?”

Jack sighed again. Daniel still had to learn what questions you didn’t ask in the military. “It’s what she didn’t do. If someone in

my team is going to 'creatively interpret' orders, I expect to be informed." So he could take the heat. Or stop a friend from ruining themselves.

"So you can take the blame for our actions?" Daniel tilted his head. "But that wouldn't be fair!"

"War's not fair," Jack quoted his first drill sergeant.

Daniel narrowed his eyes. "You want to sacrifice yourself for us but don't want us to reciprocate?"

"Yep. That's called leadership." Jack grinned at him.

"But that doesn't take into account that both Sam and I are not easy to replace," Daniel objected. "Well, Sam at least - a number of my colleagues have reversed their stance towards my theories and would probably be able to replace me, with a bit more experience. Or a lot."

Daniel was too honest for his own good. And not quite aware of how brilliant he was. "No one can replace you," Jack told him. "Your experience, your contacts, your… you-ness."

"My 'you-ness', Jack? Really?" Daniel shook his head. But he was smiling. Mission accomplished. Then his friend continued. "But then that would strengthen my point: We can take, ah, the heat."

"But it's not your job. My team, my responsibility," Jack tried again. "And the worst failure of an officer is to ignore what their soldiers are doing." Well, when they were doing something that you had to know - some things soldiers did, officers were meant to ignore.

Daniel, though, was digging his heels in. "But…"

Fortunately, a knock on the door interrupted his next argument. Jack jumped up. "OK, duty calls!"

"Or room service," Daniel retorted.

Jack grinned at him. “That would mean a break!”

But it wasn’t room service. It was Adora and Catra. And they didn’t look happy. And they were standing a bit further apart than usual, too.

Something wasn’t right on Etheria.

*****

“So, what’s wrong?”

Adora had barely set foot inside the guest quarters when Jack asked his question. Was it that obvious? Was she that obvious? She sighed. “We’ve got a disagreement about how to handle the Stargate on Etheria.”

Catra frowned at her, but Adora ignored it. SG-1 were their friends, and they wanted their advice. And you couldn’t get good advice if you weren’t honest about the problem. Besides, Jack had been at Alliance meetings before, so he knew they weren’t always united. Not to mention that Adora was a little tired of playing games right now.

“Ah. Ideals clashing with the realities of war?”

Jack didn’t sound or look smug, but he didn’t sound too sympathetic either. More… matter of factly.

“Yep,” Catra confirmed, sitting down in one of the free seats in the room. Curling up more likely - she pulled her feet up on the cushion.

Adora sighed and took the seat next to her. “It’s not as simple,” she said. “The Stargate belongs to Etheria, not to a single kingdom or even the Princess Alliance.”

“At least, that’s one opinion,” Cara cut in. Adora narrowed her eyes, but her lover grinned at her, flashing her fangs in return.

“And the other opinion would be finders keepers?” Jack was grinning as well now.

Adora suppressed a sigh. Honesty was the best policy. “Yes. There’s also the idea that since the Princess Alliance fought for Etheria and the other kingdoms didn’t, they do not deserve to have a say about the gate.”

“For the duration of the war at least,” Catra added. “But who can say how long that will take?”

“Yeah, such arrangements tend to last longer than the war - far longer,” Jack said. “There’s always something else that comes up.”

Both of them grinned at each other in a very similar way, Adora noted. And that was… well, not worrying, but kind of… disturbing. In a weird way. She took a deep breath. “And that’s why we need to decide how to handle the Stargate now, and in a fair way.”

“I think limiting access to the gate to those willing to defend Etheria is quite fair,” Catra said.

Adora wasn’t going to continue that discussion right now. “So, we wanted to know what you thought about Earth’s Stargate and how it’s being handled.”

“And what Earth will think about how you’re handling your Stargate?”

Adora nodded, though she clenched her teeth a little. Jack definitely sounded amused now.

“Yes,” Catra replied.

“Well, Earth’s Stargate is under United Nations control. But the Alliance kind of controls the United Nations, so…” Jack shrugged.

“So, officially, it belongs to all of Earth, represented by the United Nations, but de facto, it’s under Alliance control,” Daniel said.

Adora nodded.

“The Russians and the Chinese would like to change that, though,” Jack pointed out. “And they use the United Nations for that. So, business as usual.”

For Earth. But Etheria was different.

“And they would love to point out any apparent hypocrisy in our policies,” Catra said. “To manipulate us. At least they’d try.”

Jack nodded.

Adora frowned again. “But that doesn’t mean they’re wrong - not entirely. We can’t expect people to trust us if we don’t follow our own rules and ideals. And we will need a lot of people to trust us in the war.” You couldn’t persuade people to join you if you didn’t have their trust. And honesty was needed to earn trust.

“So, what are you suggesting?” Daniel asked. He looked from Adora to Catra and back. “I mean, it’s kind of obvious that you’re, ah, struggling with the decision.”

“Well, the Princess Alliance will control the gate until further notice,” Catra said.

Adora nodded - she didn’t like it, but the rest more or less agreed on that. “The question is how far we’ll limit gate travel.”

“So, you’ve got your own Russian and Chinese to deal with,” Jack said. “The information got out, then?”

“We’re not going to keep it a secret,” Adora told him. “But we haven’t announced it yet.”

“Ah.”

“And the question is, what if your Russians and Chinese want to make a deal with other kingdoms on Etheria?” Catra grinned. “I think no one wants that.”

Jack slowly nodded. “Yes. The Russians trying to influence smaller countries in your backyard to stir up trouble - where have I seen this before?”

“We’re not in the Cold War any more, Jack,” Daniel said.

“But we might start another one,” Jack retorted.

And if they banned others from using the gate, they would be ruling Etheria. Unofficially, but still.

“We can’t really afford to have to worry about another Horde forming on Etheria,” Catra said.

“But if we keep others from using the gate, we might be seen as another Horde,” Adora retorted.

“I see the problem,” Jack said. “Damned if you do, damned if you don’t.”

“Well, you could form an international organisation to control the gate, influenced to a great deal by the Princess Alliance,” Daniel suggested.

“And we call it Stargate Command?” Catra asked, grinning for a moment. Then she grew serious. “It wouldn’t really help if our Russians want to make a deal with yours. You aren’t going to prohibit them from travelling through the gate, are you?”

And that was another problem.

“Well, if you’d keep the gate a secret, you wouldn’t have to deal with that,” Jack said.

Adora glared at him. So did everyone else. Except for Teal’c, of course.

“Sorry.” But he didn’t look sorry. “But I can’t really help you here - I’m a soldier, not a politician. He shrugged. “But you could always pull the ‘unsupervised gate travel is too dangerous for you’ card.”

“Is it working for you?” Catra asked.

It was Jack’s turn to sigh. So, no.

And giving the Russians and the Chinese - hell, the rest of Earth - advanced technology wouldn’t change anything either - quite the contrary.

This was quite a mess.

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Samantha Carter was a little tired when she returned to the palace in the evening - local time; it was a bit later in Colorado already, and she was feeling it. One never really got used to the time differences while gate travelling, but one learned to ignore them. Usually, because there was an urgent problem to focus on - a life-threatening crisis tended to keep you awake until it was solved.

But they had made good progress on the Stargate - the power supply unit was working as intended, though connecting it to the gate would require a lot more time to ensure it would work without issues. Such as unstable wormholes. If they had a D.H.D. to handle that… But they hadn’t.

“So, I’ll see you at the dinner?” Entrapta asked as she hopped off the skiff that had brought them to the palace.

“Of course.” Sam nodded - she had worked up an appetite. Tiny snacks provided by her friend could only go so far. Even if they were loaded with more sugar than the average family-sized breakfast cereal box.

“Great! I’m going to fill in Hordak about what we did today!” Entrapta waved and headed down the next hallway to her own room. Or rooms.

Sam softly sighed and suppressed the urge to remind her friend to clean up as well. That would be patronising. But it had been a

long day so far.

And, she reminded herself, that was the fault of the Colonel. She still didn't glare at him when she entered their guest room, but she was a bit more professional than usual when she reported - she even saluted. Judging by his wry smile, he got the message; he didn't even comment about not saluting in the field.

"So, everything's proceeding according to schedule," he said instead.

"We're ahead of schedule, sir," she corrected him. "Depending on how connecting the power supply unit works tomorrow, we might shave off a day or two on the estimated time until the Stargate is operational."

"Good, good."

"That means we'll have more time to prepare the party," Daniel said.

Sam did glare at him. He was her friend and not a soldier, so it wasn't unprofessional.

He had the grace to wince. "Sorry… I'm just a bit excited. This is going to be an important diplomatic event. We're going to host the entire leadership of the Princess Alliance - the most important and most powerful supra-national organisation of Etheria! And a galactic power of the first tier, as far as we can tell, at least."

Her glare intensified. She would be officially responsible for organising part of the event. And taking part of the blame if anything went wrong. "Thank you for the reminder, Daniel."

"Sorry," he repeated himself. "But if you need any help, I would be happy to assist."

"I'll hold you to that."

He beamed at her in return.

And Sam sent a glance at the Colonel, who was looking far too smug right now. “And what were you doing today?” she asked Daniel.

“Oh, we were discussing possible policies for Etheria’s Stargate with Adora and Catra,” he told her. “They’re in a similar situation as we are on Earth. The Alliance needs to control the gate for the war effort, but it belongs to the entire planet.”

“They don’t like having to compromise their ideals,” the Colonel added with a chuckle.

“Jack! No one likes that!” Daniel pouted. “And it is a good sign that they struggle with the decision to limit gate travel - it shows they are taking their ideals seriously.”

The Colonel snorted. “They can do that after we’ve won the war against the snakes.”

“What good is winning a war if we betray our own ideals?” Daniel shook his head.

“We can make amends afterwards. If we lose, we won’t be able to improve anything - because we’ll all be dead. Or snaked,” the Colonel shot back, then winced.

Daniel pressed his lips together - remembering his wife, Sam was sure.

She frowned at the Colonel; he had crossed a line there - then smiled at Daniel. “Well, as you said, they won’t compromise the war effort.”

“No, they won’t. And there are several princesses who are as pragmatic as Jack here, as far as we can tell. Not that they told us explicitly, but it was pretty clear from what wasn’t said,” Daniel told her with a slight frown aimed at the Colonel.

“So, everything’s fine!” The Colonel clapped his hands. “Let’s get ready for a state dinner! We can probably use this as a rehearsal

for the big party."

Sam rolled her eyes at the joke. Daniel did the same. Sometimes, the Colonel didn't know when to drop something.

Which, she reminded himself, was usually a sign that he wasn't quite as confident as he wanted to appear. And she thought she knew why. "It will certainly provide you with more data for your report to Stargate Command, sir."

"Ah, yes. My report. Which I'll send as soon as I'm done making it." He frowned at her.

Yes, she had been correct.

"In which you'll inform them of the slight change to the party's guest list, right." Daniel was getting into it as well - he was grinning.

"A report that will need some opinions from our cultural expert," the Colonel retorted.

But Daniel smiled at that. "Oh, yes! I've got so many notes!"

Sam stifled a giggle as she went to the bathroom. After spending more than half a day working on the gate, she needed to freshen up before dinner.

*****

"...so, it's like a Princess Prom, but with far fewer rules?"

Frosta looked… interested, in Catra's opinion. As usual at a formal event such as a dinner with guests from another kingdom - or another planet in this case - the princess had been trying to appear aloof and mature (with varying degrees of success). But now she was showing a toothy smile that looked far more natural on her face.

"Well, there are rules, though they're mostly, ah, unwritten rules," Daniel replied.

"'Unwritten rules'?" Frosta cocked her head sideways with a frown. "Why didn't you write them down? The rules for the Princess Prom are well-documented."

"And far too long," Catra heard Mermista mutter under her breath. She chuckled in agreement.

"Is this an attempt to control who gets to attend the party by controlling information?" Perfuma asked, leaning forward. "Or is there a tradition that whoever invites you needs to teach you the rules?"

Perfect! "Well, Jack invited us," Catra said, grinning at his wince.

"Ah, it's not quite like that," Daniel said. "More formal events do have established protocol - established over centuries in some cases. But the New Year's Party at Stargate Command is not a formal event like that, nor does it have such a long tradition."

"We've only been around for a few years, after all," O'Neill cut in. "But the rules are mostly common sense. No fighting, no drinking excessively, no overly public displays of affection…"

"That sounds very formal to me," Adora commented with a frown.

"They mean no public sex, I bet," Catra said.

O'Neill glared at her for a moment, but she ignored that. Watching others blush was more interesting.

"No public sex - no public displays of sex - is a written rule, actually. A law, indeed," Daniel said. "Well, in the USA. There could be countries where it's allowed, but I can't recall one off-hand."

"And why would you know that, Daniel, hm?" O'Neill smirked.

"Because I had to look it up for a report once!" Daniel retorted, blushing. "Not because of what you are insinuating!"

"Let's drop this. I don't think anyone is planning to have sex on the dinner table," Glimmer commented. "Right, Catra?"

Was that a challenge? Wrong move, Sparkles! "I would never plan anything like that," Catra shot back. "Such things are usually spontaneous, right, Adora?"

Her lover blinked, then blushed. "Not like that! I mean, not in public! We'd never… Catra!"

Catra snickered, then laughed. Half the table was frowning at her, but it had been worth it.

"So, no public displays of sex," Entrapta's voice cut through the sudden silence. "Noted."

Daniel cleared his throat. "Anyway, yes, since it was originally meant for the members of Stargate Command, the written rules were Air Force regulations."

"'Were'?" Netossa asked.

"Since Stargate Command was recently expanded from the Air Force into a multi-national unit, the regulations were adapted and expanded."

"So, you do have written rules," Frosta said with a slight sniff.

"Yes." Adora nodded. "I have a copy if you want to read them. Though they are a little confusing in some spots. And contradict themselves in at least two areas. Unless I am mistaken."

Daniel blinked, and O'Neill grinned. "Well, it was a rush job, so you probably aren't mistaken. Did you inform the command council?"

"No. I thought that would be presumptuous since we don't have to follow those regulations," Adora explained.

"We don't?" Frosta perked up.

"We aren't members of Stargate Command," Adora told her. "So, we aren't subject to their regulations. It's a little different in the Alliance, but unless you're formally assigned to a unit, you generally don't have to follow any regulations from other militaries. And then there are grandfather clauses to consider as well."

"Those mean that if something was allowed under your old regulations, it can't be deemed illegal if you join a unit or formation," Bow explained before anyone could ask what that meant. "Provided it was already, ah, going on when you joined."

"It's mostly so we don't have to deal with that silly 'no fraternisation' rule of theirs," Catra added with a glance at O'Neill and Sam. Who, she noted, reacted in the exact same way of pressing their lips together and trying to ignore the dig. She snickered again.

"Anyway," Daniel spoke up again. "It's really just informal or common sense, as far as rules go. It's a lot like when you're visiting someone's home."

"For a dinner, not for a kegger," O'Neill added.

"What's a kegger?" Frosta asked.

"A party where copious amounts of alcohol, usually beer from a keg, is drunk," Daniel explained.

"Which this isn't," Sam spoke up. "In fact, there's no alcohol available at the party."

"Officially," O'Neill said. "I mean, no alcohol on the base, yes."

“No alcohol?” Mermista frowned. “That doesn’t sound like much of a party.”

Frosta nodded in agreement, which caused Micah to frown at her and then at Mermista.

“It’s a military base. Alcohol, enlisted soldiers and weapons don’t mix well,” O’Neill told her. “We would rather not have anyone starting a drunk tank-tossing competition at the party.”

“I only did that once!” Scorpia complained. “And it was a dare!”

Catra shook her head as everyone stared at her friend.

“Daniel, make a note that tank-tossing competitions are against the rules,” O’Neill said in a dry voice.

“I didn’t think we have tanks in the Mountain.” Daniel looked puzzled.

“Not inside the Mountain, but they beefed up security outside,” O’Neill explained. “Something about repelling a landing operation from orbit.” He shrugged. “The army wanted to feel useful, I guess.”

“Ah.”

“So, what about dancing? Are there formal dances we need to know?” Spinnerella asked.

“Ah… no,” Daniel said. “Dancing is more… informal.”

“Don’t drunkenly dance on tables is another rule,” O’Neill said. “Don’t dance on tables, period.”

“Why would anyone dance on tables?” Frosta asked.

“Well, it’s really…Ooof” Sea Hawk’s attempt to answer was cut off by Mermista’s elbow.

"Noted!" Entrapta piped up. "You seem to be the rules expert, Jack. Any other rules we need to know?"

"Ah, I wouldn't say I am an expert…" O'Neill started to say.

"Yes, he's the expert on rules," Sam interrupted him.

"Probably because he's broken every rule at least once," Catra whispered to Adora while O'Neill sent a frown at Sam.

Her lover tried to hide her chuckle, and Catra leaned back with a satisfied smirk. This was a very amusing dinner - and the food was great as well.

It was good to be home.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

When he heard the alarm go off - beeping softly next to his head so the others wouldn't be woken as well - Jack O'Neill was tempted to turn it off and just stay in bed. For a moment, at least. But duty called.

So he got up, stretched - it was still great and a bit suspicious to not feel any of the familiar old aches any more - and nodded at Teal'c, who was, unsurprisingly, already up. Or still up. It was hard to tell with him using Jaffa meditation techniques. "Morning, Teal'c."

"Good morning, Colonel O'Neill."

Daniel and Carter were still asleep. No surprise there, either - Daniel had stayed up far too late typing up his notes from the dinner, and Carter… had worked too hard before and had still tried to 'go over the latest code' instead of going to bed until Jack had ordered her to rest.

It had been a long day for Jack as well, of course. The dinner had felt more like an interrogation sometimes. Or like trying to hand-feed sharks in a feeding frenzy. Wrangling alien dignitaries was Daniel's job, for crying out loud!

And Jack would have expected Adora, Glimmer and the others familiar with Earth culture to handle the questions of the other princesses. But it seemed they weren't quite as familiar with Earth culture as he had thought - their explanations sometimes were a little off. And sometimes a bit too on point.

Shaking his head, he entered the bathroom. He wasn't looking forward to explaining the new additions to the New Year's Party to Stargate Command, so he'd better look perfectly presentable when he made the call at the gate.

*****

Gate Area, Outside Bright Moon, Etheria, December 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Yes, General. The entire leadership of the Princess Alliance - and their plus ones - expressed their desire to attend the party." Jack O'Neill suppressed a wince at his superior's expression on the screen next to the gate. Maybe he should have used the daisy-chain communication bot network Entrapta and Carter had set up instead of waiting for the scheduled gate contact. The lag might be useful for once.

"I see." Hammond nodded briskly.

Jack continued. "And since Adora, Glimmer and the others were already invited to the party…"

"By you." Another short nod.

"Just following orders to foster good relations, sir." Jack kept his expression bland. "Anyway, they assume that means the entire Alliance leadership was invited."

“I see,” Hammond repeated himself, then turned his head to look at Haig.

The limey nodded. “We were already planning to accommodate high-ranking alien diplomats. A few more shouldn’t be a problem, provided we prepare accordingly.”

Well, this general got it. Jack nodded. Of course, the additional guests were not familiar with Earth culture at all and included a moody and, as far as Jack could tell, spoilt teenager who could cover the entire base in a glacier if she felt like it, a Scorpion-woman with pincers for hands who threw tanks around for fun, her lover who could turn a potted office plant into a jungle with a thought, and a serial arsonist, so things might require slightly more thorough preparations. Hell, someone had to ensure that no drunk soldier hit on the royal teenager. Or gave her alcohol. Well, that was…

“So, given your familiarity with the Etherians, I think you should be in charge of those preparations, Colonel.”

…apparently now Jack’s job. Damn. And Hammond was smiling faintly. But Jack nodded. “Yes, sir.”

“Good. While you are on Etheria, ensure that they are familiar with our rules and expectations, Colonel,” Hammond told him.

“Oh, we’ve already started on that,” Jack replied. “They understand the gist of it already.” A bit away, working on her computer, Carter coughed, but Jack ignored that. “I emphasised that we frown on tank-tossing competitions.”

“What?” Hammond narrowed his eyes and scowled.

“Pardon?” Haig raised his eyebrows but didn’t react otherwise.

“Apparently, you should never dare Scorpia to throw a tank. She can and will do it. And since the only tanks at the base are ours…” Jack shrugged. “It’s been handled.”

"It better have been handled, Colonel!" Hammond growled. "We'll impress on our troops that our guests will be treated with the utmost courtesy."

Jack swallowed his 'they'd better, or they might get frozen, drowned and turned to fertiliser' comment. "Yes, sir."

"Anything else?"

"That would be all," Jack replied. They had already sent the progress report and revised estimates from Carter and Entrapta.

"Good. Stargate Command out."

The screen went dark, and Jack sighed. "Wanna bet that in five minutes, all the spooks are making plans on how best to approach our guests?" he asked Carter.

"No, sir."

"We'll have to be on the ball. And we'll have to warn the Etherians," Jack went on.

"Yes, sir." She nodded curtly. And he caught the hint of a grin. "I trust you will handle this with your usual efficiency, sir. I am, unfortunately, fully occupied with my work on the Stargate, so I cannot possibly assist you."

He frowned at her. Maybe he deserved this. But only a little - and she didn't have to be so smug about it.

Well, at least Daniel would be helping. Eagerly.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Are you sure we can't claim diplomatic immunity and bring alcohol to the party, Glimmer?"

“Yes, Frosta, I am sure. That’s not how diplomatic immunity works on Earth.”

Adora wondered who had told Frosta about diplomatic immunity.

“But Daniel said it made you immune to punishment.” Frosta frowned - well, scowled.

Adora shook her head. They should be talking about the diplomatic trouble Swift Wind had caused - was causing - not about the New Year’s Party.

“It would also be rude,” Perfuma commented.

“Why do you want to drink alcohol so badly, anyway?” Glimmer asked.

“Just drink before we leave from here!” Catra interjected before Frosta could answer. “But not so much that you can’t walk any more.”

“It’s not about getting drunk!” Frosta protested with a glare at Catra. “It’s about preserving our sovereignty.”

Adora wasn’t sure she believed the claim - but she hoped that this was true. A drunk Frosta was a recipe for disaster. Well, any drunk princess was a disaster waiting to happen. She almost blushed when she remembered what she had done when she had been, well, it hadn’t been alcohol, but she had acted like a drunk in that Horde base with Scorpia.

“Then it shouldn’t bother you that alcohol is not permitted at the party.” Catra showed her fangs in a toothy grin at Frosta. The princess opened her mouth to snap back something, but Catra went on: “Besides, if you want a real party, we can go clubbing on Earth later.”

What? Adora stared at her lover.

“What?” Glimmer blurted out.

“Clubbing?” Frosta blinked.

“You want to hunt seals?” Bow asked.

“Seal hunting?” Catra looked confused.

“Yes, because on Earth, they use clubs to kill them… I saw it in a documentary,” he explained.

“Clubbing is going out and visiting bars and nightclubs on Earth,” Catra told him.

“Ah.”

“They hunt seals with clubs?” Mermista asked.

Bow winced. “Baby seals.”

Adora gasped. “Baby seals?” Those cute white animals? But…

Frosta looked puzzled before frowning at her. “They have the softest pelts.” She rubbed the white fur lining her top, Adora noticed.

Oh. Ugh. She winced. *That* was where the fur came from?

“It’s actually quite controversial on Earth - as is wearing fur at all,” Bow explained. “At least in some countries, they want to ban it.”

“Really? But they eat meat, don’t they?” Scorpia asked.

“Yes,” Catra replied. “And fish.”

“That sounds… not very principled,” Perfuma remarked with a frown.

“Some people on Earth don’t eat meat,” Glimmer said. “And some eat almost nothing but meat, or so it seems. There are a lot of humans on Earth.”

“Ah, yes, I forgot.” Scorpia nodded.

This was her chance to bring the discussion back topic! “Anyway,” Adora spoke up, “Speaking about animals. We need to talk about how to deal with, ah, horses.”

“You mean Swift Wind,” Mermista told her. “And his raiding.”

“Pirate queen,” Catra whispered next to Adora.

Glimmer glared at her, then sighed. “Yes. As I have discovered, there’s some misconception amongst some of our neighbours that Swift Wind is acting in the name of the Princess Alliance.”

Catra chuckled.

“What?” Frosta frowned. “What is he doing?”

“He’s ‘liberating’ horses,” Netossa told her. “And then bringing them to Bright Moon.”

“Really?”

Micah, who was looking embarrassed, Adora noticed, nodded. “We’ve been compensating the other kingdoms and moving the horses to pastures.”

“Which hasn’t helped with the impression others have gotten about our stance towards his activities,” Glimmer said with a frown.

“I am sorry,” Adora said, wincing. “I had no idea he was doing this in my absence.” Well, she remembered some comments of his which, in hindsight, should have alerted her, but… no one else had realised anything either.

“The question is: What are we doing about this? We can’t have a reputation as horse thieves,” Glimmer said.

“And we can’t let the other kingdoms think that we will attack them if they won’t let him continue,” Adora added. “They’ll think we’re bullies.”

“Or a new Horde,” Perfuma added.

“Yes. Some already commented on that,” Mermista said. “We have a lot of former Horde soldiers in the Alliance now, so some princesses claim to be worried.”

“What?” Perfuma scowled, which was quite rare for her. “The Scorpion Kingdom is completely peaceful! Anyone can see that!”

“Well, we’ve been preparing for the war against the Goa’uld, so that could have left the wrong impression on some,” Scorpia added, scratching her head with one pincer.

“Yes, all our kingdoms have been gearing up for war,” Mermista said. “That’s not new, though. And the fleet in orbit is kind of hard to miss.”

That was true. The other kingdoms must be feeling intimidated.

“We can’t exactly disarm so the other princesses won’t feel threatened,” Netossa said. “Just tell Swift Wind to stop and tell the countries who lost horses it was a mistake.”

“And what if he doesn’t want to stop? He feels strongly about horses,” Spinnerella said.

“Quite understandable, really,” Perfuma added.

“We can’t let him steal every horse on Etheria,” Glimmer spoke up. “We’re already running short on available pastures. And imagine if he starts doing this on Earth!”

“They eat horses there. Well, in some countries,” Catra pointed out.

Adora winced. If Swift Wind heard about that… “But we have to do something about this.” It wasn’t right to push other kingdoms around.

“Well… We could replace all of them with oxen, I guess - or maybe bots,” Bow suggested. “But that would still leave the question of what to do with them once they are free.”

“Just let them roam in the wilderness?” Catra shrugged.

“People and animals will hunt them. And capture them,” Glimmer pointed out.

“We could propose a treaty about the treatment of horses,” Perfuma said. “So they aren’t hunted or worked too hard.”

Adora wasn’t sure if Swift Wind would be satisfied with that, but it might be a start. Of course, if other princesses were afraid that the Princess Alliance was backing Swift Wind with their militaries, then they might think this treaty was the same deal and they would still feel bullied and resent it. And then there was the matter of the Stargate on top of that… “This is such a mess,” she muttered.

“Well, it could be worse,” Catra said. Adora looked at her. “Imagine if Swift Wind and some of those PETA guys met.”

Adora shuddered at the thought while Catra had to explain to the others what PETA was and wanted.

*****

Going Home Part 4

Gate Area, Outside Bright Moon, Etheria, December 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

The Horde fortifications being put up around the gate were a stark contrast to what Samantha Carter had started to think of as 'Etherian style'. They lacked the smoother curves and elegant lines of Bright Moon's architecture - or the clean style of Horde frigates. They looked more utilitarian. Reduced to what was functional, nothing else. Bare metal and concrete, mostly, if of a slightly exotic colour. And they looked… cheap, Sam decided would fit best. She could be mistaken, of course, but since she had seen how they had been set up, she didn't think she was.

Entrapta confirmed her suspicions. "Glimmer's still undecided on the final design for the main building for the gate base. Oh, and there's some talk about Bright Moon's architecture being presumptuous, so even once she decides on the style, the rest have to approve it." She shrugged. "I don't get what's wrong with just using Horde bunkers - except that we could still improve on them, of course. But they serve perfectly fine if you need a base."

Sam nodded. "They might not want this to be the thing a visitor sees first upon arriving on Etheria," she pointed out.

"Oh? I guess that might be true. It's still weird, though." Entapta shrugged, then pushed her visor up and looked around. "Everyone knows we won the war. And most of the Horde soldiers deserted or joined the Alliance against Horde Prime, anyway. And his tech looks quite different. Although Hordak might have picked a similar design to Horde Prime's if he would have had the resources available, I think. Not anymore, of course. But back then, probably."

Sam didn't really want to talk about Hordak - the former Warlord still gave her the creeps, for all that she understood how he ended up doing what he did. That he wasn't imprisoned, exiled or

executed was a testament to how different the Etherians - at least the princesses - saw such things. “Well, unless they come to a decision quickly, this might end up being quite a long-lasting temporary solution,” she said.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded with a smile. “The Bright Moon building techniques aren’t as fast as Horde technology, either. Although that might be because they do not use bots as much. Or at all.” She pouted a little. “I hoped bots would become more accepted in the other kingdoms, but despite their help in rebuilding after the war, many princesses seem to distrust them. Even the smart bots, like Emily.”

The bot beeped in agreement - and Sam could detect some sadness as well in the tone. So she swallowed her comment that the princesses might distrust intelligent bots even more than the dumb ones. “Well, they might associate bots with the Horde,” she said instead. “It’s hard to overcome such impressions.”

“Well, it’s stupid. We’re not at war any more.” Entrapta patted Emily’s dome with her hair. “But I am sure that they’ll warm up to you sooner or later, Emily! We just have to keep showing how great you and your fellow bots are!” She turned to Sam with a smile. “Our bot network should help with that - the spy bots are so useful! And so brave!”

Useful, undoubtedly. Although Sam was sure (and had ensured) that they hadn’t sent any smart bots abroad. She would rather not see sapient machines spreading through the Galaxy. So she wouldn’t call them brave. But she wouldn’t correct Entrapta - it was a minor quibble. “Yes,” she said, nodding. “I assume that former Horde soldiers are faced with similar problems?”

“Well, yes, but they are mainly settled in the Scorpion Kingdom, anyway.”

Which was ruled by a former Horde Force Captain. Who was the partner of a key member of the Princess Alliance. Some might even suspect that the Horde merely changed the name of their

country. Sam doubted that - she had met Scorpia, after all, and Perfuma's influence on her was also quite obvious, in Sam's opinion - but perception rarely matched reality. Especially when it came to grudges.

She might ask Daniel about this - his insight might be useful. And they would have to find out if other princesses in the Alliance harboured such grudges. The last thing Sam wanted was a row breaking out between two princesses deep inside Cheyenne Mountain.

She was rather fond of her lab, after all, even if she would have to move soon anyway, and the collateral damage that such a row could cause… Before she could think of a way to ask Entrapta about it without giving offence, Emily turned and beeped, her blaster cannon aimed. Something was up.

Sam quickly walked over to her pack, where she had put her carbine as well. She should have kept it on her, damn it! The Colonel wouldn't be happy if he heard about this.

"Oh. Perimeter scouts report that we're about to have visitors," Entrapta said - she had pushed her visor down and must be checking the feeds from the bots. "I think."

"Where are they?" Sam asked. They were in the middle of the camp, behind the field fortifications, but if someone took to the hills nearby…

Entrapta pointed at the largest hill around them. "They're up there."

Spies, Sam thought.

She quickly joined Entrapta, putting Emily between them and the hill. "Do you have a visual feed?"

"Uh… yes, let me link it to the… thank you, Emily!"

Sam looked at the screen Emily had handed to Entrapta. It showed half a dozen people - mostly humans except for one, no, two… satyrs, she'd call them on Earth. Diverse appearance, no uniforms - though a few of the outfits they were wearing looked as if they once were part of a uniform. And all of them were armed.

Sam recalled what she knew about Etheria's history. "I don't think they're visitors," she said. "They look like bandits."

"Bandits? In Bright Moon?" Entrapta blinked. "Are you sure?"

"No," Sam admitted. "But weren't they trying to sneak up on us?"

"Well, we are in the middle of a new base… which kinda looks like a Horde base, now that I think about it." Entrapta looked a bit embarrassed. "They might not trust us."

"But sneaking into Bright Moon?" Sam asked while watching the six men and women slowly crawl up to the top of the hill. "They haven't noticed the spy bot?"

"No, they didn't! She's a sneaky one!" Entrapta smiled.

Sam felt herself smiling as well but quickly grew serious again. She turned to look at the guards at the gate and those patrolling the close perimeter. "Do they know?"

"Oops, I forgot that they aren't in the network. Glimmer should really update Bright Moon communications." Entrapta looked sheepish, then she turned, her hair keeping the screen steady, and yelled: "Sergeant Slater! We have visitors - potential visitors - on the hill there."

"Armed ones," Sam added, and the sergeant nodded and started bellowing orders.

The people on the hilltop hadn't missed that, and Sam saw that they were falling back, out of sight of the base but not of the spy

bot, and were looking around - trying to spot who had discovered them, she realised. That would fit former soldiers.

The short squabble that followed, ending with one of the goat people getting cuffed on the head and sent sprawling on the ground by the apparent leader, would fit deserters as well. But they were standing their ground now - even returning to the hilltop. Bandits or not, they had guts, as the Colonel would say.

Or they were desperate - or feared their leader more than they feared Bright Moon's soldiers. Then again, if Bright Moon's regular prisons were even half as nice as their converted guest rooms for special prisoners…

She studied the leader. He was a human but as tall as Teal'c and, as far as Sam could tell, even wider. And not much, if anything at all, of that bulk seemed to be fat.

"Should we go and talk to them?" Entrapta asked as Slater sent two squads up the hill, one gong around it to cut off a potential escape.

"Won't Slater take them to us?" Sam asked.

"Well… I dunno?" Entrapta cocked her head. "If we want him to, he would, since this is a Princess Alliance base. Technically. And I am a princess."

Sam reminded herself that for all her experience in a war and as the absolute ruler of a sovereign kingdom, Entrapta wasn't exactly what the Colonel would call 'leadership material'. "I think we should talk to them," she said.

"Alright!" Entrapta raised her multitool and pushed a button. "Sergeant Slater? Could you lead them to the base so we can talk to them?"

Sam heard the sergeant reply: "That might be dangerous, Princess."

“Well, do you think they’re dangerous?” Entrapta asked, cocking her head.

Yes, Sam thought. “We can talk to them behind Entrapta’s shield,” she suggested. “Outside the base.”

Slater agreed, and so Entrapta gave the order. Technically.

Sam focused on the upcoming talk, but she couldn’t help wondering how this would have played out in a joint American/Princess Alliance mission.

It didn’t take the soldiers and their guests long to descend from the hill - with the strangers in the middle, between two columns of soldiers. Entrapta and Sam met them in front of the gate, with Entrapta at their back and the bot’s shield in front of them.

“Hello!” Entrapta waved. “I’m Entrapta, Princess of Dryl! And this is Sam Carter, my friend and science buddy! She’s from… a place I’m not supposed to tell you. Who are you?”

Instead of giving his name, the man sneered. “We know she’s from space. And we know she arrived through the gate with her friends.”

So much for OpSec, Sam thought, pressing her lips together.

“Oh.” Entrapta blinked, then smiled. “Good! If you know that already, then we don’t have to explain things.”

Sam suppressed a wince.

“Yes,” a goatwoman blurted out. “We know what you are doing! You want to keep the portal to yourself! And we won’t accept that!”

The leader glared at her, and she cowed her head. Then he turned back to frown at Entrapta. “We’re sick of the princesses keeping all the good land to themselves while we starve in the

desert! We want to move to another planet with fertile land!" he all but yelled. The rest of his group cheered in agreement.

Sam wanted to curse. She wasn't an expert on Etherian politics, but she knew this would be trouble.

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Bright Moon, Etheria, December 28th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"They want to use the Stargate to emigrate to another planet?"

"That's what Sam just said," Catra replied to Glimmer's probably rhetorical question. Glimmer shot her a glare, and Catra put on her most fake 'earnestly helpful' expression. She didn't ask if her friend's ears were OK, but she wriggled her own a little. Then she winced - Adora had just pinched her thigh under the table with a whispered 'be nice'.

"Yes." Entrapta nodded with an honestly earnest expression. "They said they were sick of living in the Crimson Waste, and that all the fertile land was already taken, so they want to move to another world." She tilted her head. "And they said that the Stargate belonged to everyone, not just princesses."

Catra couldn't help snorting at that. "That sounds like former Horde soldiers."

This comment earned her a few more frowns, but Adora nodded in agreement. "Yes. That would fit what we were taught in the Horde."

Scorpia nodded as well. "Yeah. It's a bit different for me since I was a Force Captain, and well, everyone loves Perfuma…" She exchanged a sappy look with her lover. "...but there's still some, ah, suspicion towards princesses in some parts of the Scorpion Kingdom."

Quite significant parts, Catra thought. A lot of Horde soldiers were probably fed up with princesses - and with herself, of course, she

added with a mental snort - after the war. Well, too bad for them; without the Princess Alliance, Etheria would have been conquered and then destroyed.

"Former Horde soldiers who turned bandits don't like us? What a surprise!" Mermista scoffed. "They're just pirates on land."

"We don't know that," Adora objected. "Not everyone in the Crimson Waste is a bandit. Huntara is a good friend."

And a fellow member of the Princess Alliance. Sort of - she hadn't really been at any meeting since the end of the war, not after she had left to 'liberate' the Crimson Waste from the Horde.

"And speaking of her: What is Huntara doing? The Crimson Waste is hers. She's been too busy conquering it to attend any meeting since the war, so she should be handling this!" Mermista commented, echoing Catra's thoughts.

"I don't think she has finished conquering it," Catra pointed out. "It's a very large territory, and while the number of areas with any strategic value is limited to the places with water, there are still quite a lot of them, and her forces will have taken casualties fighting the Horde and Horde Prime. Also, she might have lost some followers once the Horde was beaten and stopped being a threat." Catra knew what the Crimson Waste was like and she had no doubt that half the better bandits there would rather rule an oasis of their own than follow Huntara.

"Ugh." Mermista rolled her eyes. "I had to retake Salineas and didn't take that long."

"You are a princess," Glimmer pointed out. "You had the support of your kingdom's soldiers and people. Huntara doesn't have that."

The same people and soldiers who had deserted Mermista once before, when it had looked as if she would lose, but Catra refrained from pointing that out. Mermista could be prickly about that, even if she sometimes mentioned it herself.

"We should still ask her about this. She is the closest we have to a princess in the Crimson Waste," Perfuma cut in. "If her people want to emigrate through the Stargate because they are sick of living in the desert, she needs to know." She perked up, "I could help her improve the land!" With a glance at Scoria, she added: "Though that would cut into my work in the Scorpion Kingdom."

"Oh, that'd be OK. You've done so much for us already." Scorpia beamed at her. "And I think we're doing good now. Though we'll have to wait and see how the war changes this."

Catra snorted aloud. "I don't really think this is just about not wanting to live in the desert any more," she said. "Etheria has enough, more than enough, fertile land for people to settle, doesn't it?" She shook her head. "I think they just don't want to live under a princess's rule." They were, by and large, former Horde soldiers turned bandits, after all. Instead of joining the Princess Alliance.

"Well, technically, Huntara isn't a princess," Bow commented. "She hasn't shown any magical power so far. But she's still going to conquer the Crimson Waste and rule it like a princess, so the difference for those under her rule is probably moot."

Catra nodded. The former Horde soldier had made her views clear - 'the strong make the rules', if she recalled it correctly. Which meant the strong ruled. Though Catra wasn't yet sure if Huntara was strong enough - or smart enough - to rule the Waste. Time would tell.

Glimmer huffed. "That's all interesting, and finding out if you can become a princess without magical powers is certainly a complicated topic, but we need to decide what we do about their demand to use the gate to colonise another world."

"We can't just let them conquer another world!" Adora blurted out. "That would be wrong!"

“Just send them to an empty world,” Mermista retorted. “Better than having them trying to carve out their own kingdom on Etheria.”

“We would have to find an empty world for them first,” Bow pointed out. “And it would have to be a world able to sustain a kingdom. Finding one, and ensuring that they can survive and thrive there will take some time - possibly a long time.”

“And it would take resources we need for the war,” Glimmer added. “We have more important things to do than cater to a small group of deserters and bandits - whose new world we would then have to protect as well so they don’t end up conquered by the Goa’uld.”

“But do we know how big their group actually is?” Adora asked. “And how many similar groups exist?”

That was a good question. Catra nodded. And had to suppress a snort when she saw the glances the others were exchanging.

How many people on Etheria would want to leave instead of living under a princess? She had a feeling that there were more than a handful.

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Another evening, another state dinner. If this continued, then Jack O’Neill was sure that in just a week, he would’ve hobnobbed more with royalty than every general at the Pentagon put together managed in a year. Or at all - it wasn’t as if they met actual kings and queens very often in their line of work. And the food was to die for.

On the other hand, for a dinner involving multiple heads of state - absolute rulers, even - the whole shebang felt more like a family dinner. With all the squabbling you expected over the holidays.

As long as you didn’t think too much about the fact that half the people present had the power to turn you into a paste on the floor

with a thought, of course.

“So, you’ve got a group of discontents who want to emigrate to a planet without princesses?” he asked once Mermista and her ‘consort’ had stopped reenacting a scene from Much Ado About Nothing or something. He managed not to smirk. Not much, at least, and he hid his mouth by taking a sip from the excellent wine right afterwards.

“You didn’t fill him in?” Glimmer raised her eyebrows at Carter.

“I did,” Carter replied. Very reservedly.

And Glimmer tilted her head to raise her eyebrows at him.

Jack took it in stride and grinned. Playing dumb didn’t work all the time, especially not with people who knew you, and he was no Peter Falk, but it was best to keep in practice. “Yeah, I heard the gist. But I guess you’ve talked about it in more detail.”

“We did.” Glimmer nodded. “But we haven’t decided how to react to their demands yet.”

“We need to carefully consider the issue,” Perfuma said. She really had flowers in her hair at all times. Jack wondered if they grew on her head - it wouldn’t be the weirdest thing he had seen so far in Etheria. “And we need more information.”

“You can’t trust the words of deserters turned bandits,” Mermista said.

“We don’t know if they are bandits,” Perfuma objected. “Just because they come from the Crimson Waste.”

“They *claim* to come from the Crimson Waste,” Mermista retorted. “They might be pirates who survived the sinking of their ship - or deserted their crew in a port.”

“Indeed!” Her consort, the smuggler, spoke up, nodding. “Having broken the sacred bond of captain and crew, they would naturally

attempt to hide their betrayal by laying claim to a new identity." He stood, raising his fist, but Mermista pulled him down into his seat before he could… do whatever he had planned. Probably something dramatic, in Jack's opinion.

"I don't think we should assume the worst of them," Adora said.

"But we also shouldn't overlook that they sneaked into Bright Moon," Catra added. "Of course, that's not a big achievement since you can sneak entire herds of horses over the border without your patrols noticing, but it's a little suspicious."

"Swift Wind is a special case."

Glimmer was frowning at her, Jack noticed. But… "Swift Wind is smuggling horses?" he couldn't help asking.

"He sees it as freeing slaves," Catra explained with a grin as Adora blushed.

Daniel blinked. "Are horses sapient on Etheria?"

"No. They're animals," Glimmer told him.

"They're as smart as dumb bots, I think," Entrapta said. "It's hard to measure that. Especially without invasive surgery."

"Ah."

"But Swift Wind was a normal horse himself before Adora accidentally turned him into what he is," Bow said. "So, his views are… kinda coloured by that."

"And he's trying to pull a Planet of the Apes?" Jack blurted out. He winced when everyone looked confused. "Ah, that's a movie from Earth. About an astronaut landing on a planet where humans are dumb like apes, and smart apes rule the world. "

"Sounds like a weird movie," Catra commented. "But not the weirdest I've seen."

“So, back to your wanna-be colonists,” Jack said quickly when he saw that Daniel wanted to expand on the topic. The last thing he wanted was to discuss old science fiction movies. And accidentally starting a fear of a horse uprising.

“It’s quite understandable that they don’t want to live in the Crimson Waste,” Perfuma said with an earnest expression. “It’s a giant desert, and the plants are mostly cactuses. Which are fine plants, but they can be a little prickly.” She blinked, then blushed as a few people - including Jack - snickered. “I didn’t mean it like that! I meant they can be hard to control!”

“But doesn’t your planet have more habitable regions? You only have about fifty million people, and Etheria is as large as Earth,” Daniel pointed out.

“Etheria has plenty of room for everyone,” Glimmer said. “Without counting mountains or deserts.”

“There’s nothing wrong with mountains. Dryl’s perfectly fine,” Entrapta objected.

“But it’s not a farming country.”

“No, but we trade ore for food.” Entrapta nodded.

“They want fertile land, which usually means good farming land,” Bow cut in. “Though they didn’t actually state that they wanted to farm, did they?”

“They didn’t. That’s why we need more information before we can actually discuss the issue properly and come to a decision,” Glimmer said.

“But we can’t just let them colonise a planet anyway,” Adora pointed out. “What if there are already people living on it?”

“Yes,” Daniel, of course, agreed readily. “The history of Earth shows the consequences of such colonisation. The United States’ history in particular.”

The way everyone nodded with a serious expression made it clear that Glimmer and the others had filled them in about that particular part of human history.

"But sending them to an empty planet, as tempting as it is, is not a good idea either," Catra said. "They'd need protection so the Goa'uld can't take them over. Unless they all die off, of course, if their crops fail. Or if they find out that knowing how to raid doesn't let you survive when there's nothing to raid."

"Oh, yes!" Daniel nodded. "Colonies on Earth often required constant support from the country of origin, at least in the beginning, and many failed anyway. Though the Stargate would make supplying a settlement far easier, I guess."

"That begs the question of whether we want to support such a colony or not," Glimmer said. "They obviously don't care for us - or anyone else except themselves. Why should we let them settle a planet and then protect it while entire worlds full of people are occupied by the Goa'uld?"

That was a good question, Jack had to admit. Even though he liked the thought of Etherians striking out to live free from the rule of magical princesses. In an abstract way, though - the nitty gritty details were much less appealing.

Though that wouldn't really bother the press back home if they caught wind of it. He could already see the headlines and talking points about a second Mayflower. And at least some back home would want to emulate them as well and make their own country. A country that would probably be very similar to what the pilgrims had wanted to create.

Yeah, it wasn't really amusing any more.

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Above Bright Moon, Etheria, December 29th, 1998 (Earth Time)

She could do this. She had to do it. Well, there were alternatives, but it was the right thing to do. Probably.

Adora closed her eyes and sighed. What should she do?

“Is something wrong?”

She forced herself to smile at Swift Wind’s question - he had turned his head and was looking at her while they flew through a cloud. “No, no,” she lied. “I was just thinking. About the war.”

Lying to her friend felt awful.

“Ah! I can understand - it must be a daunting task to face such evil. An Empire built on slavery - oh, I understand perfectly. I am waging my own war against slavery here on Etheria, as you know.”

Adora winced. Fortunately, Swift Wind was looking ahead again and missed it. Just the topic she had been torn about. Enough - she would face this head-on! As she should have from the start. “So I’ve been told,” she said. “You’ve been taking horses to Bright Moon.”

“Micah has been very helpful in housing them free and safe,” he replied. “No slaver would dare to mess with the most powerful kingdom on Etheria. Of course, now that you’re back, it should become even easier to free horses - who would dare to challenge She-Ra and her faithful mount?”

Adora blinked. Was he expecting her to help him with stealing horses? She-Ra, a thief? For a brief moment, she imagined herself wearing a mask. And shuddered at the thought of looking like Shadow Weaver. Maybe a full suit with a helmet… No! Everyone would know it was her, anyway - she was usually the only one riding Swift Wind, after all. And he would probably announce her anyway. “Well, they knew you’re my friend, my mount, already,” she said.

"Yes, but they also knew you were gone. Some might have even hoped that you'd stay gone! But now that you're back, they know they've got no chance to stop us!"

"Yeah…" She winced again. "But I'll still be busy with the war against the Goa'uld."

"Of course! And I will fight at your side! But trust me, freeing horses is easy - you can do it to relax and unwind. And there's nothing more satisfying than seeing them free of the cruel yokes that were forced on them, galloping over the fields and hills!"

Adora pressed her lips together so she wouldn't curse. Swift Wind was… well, he was clearly fully invested in this. And what could she say? That he should let his people - he was a horse, after all, just a special one - just be? Well, she had been planning - considering - that, but now… "Do you know how many horses are on Etheria?" she asked.

"No." He laughed. "But I won't rest until the last one has been freed and slavery vanquished!"

She would have to talk to Glimmer.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 29th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"You want us to keep supporting him?"

Adora winced a little - Glimmer's outburst was a bit loud. Well, she was under a lot of stress, what with having to deal with all the issues that Micah had left for her to decide during their absence. Still… She nodded. "He is set on liberating all horses."

"We already knew that." Her friend shook her head. "So what? That means we have to go along with it?"

Yes. But she didn't say that. "Well, we have been going along with it, haven't we?"

“Dad has.” Glimmer sighed. “But we can’t keep doing this - do you know how many horses are on Etheria?”

Adora shook her head. “That’s what I wanted to ask you.”

Glimmer scowled in return.

“I guess you don’t know either, huh?” Catra cut in from where she was sprawled on Glimmer’s couch eating a tuna sandwich.

Glimmer’s scowl deepened.

“We can find out,” Bow said, smiling at everyone. “There should be records.”

“You record the number of horses? Do you tax them?” Catra asked.

“No, we don’t tax horses,” Glimmer said. “But Mom ordered a count in case we had to confiscate them for the war effort.”

“You wanted to fight us with horse cavalry?” Catra asked. “Or mounted infantry?”

“Mounted infantry, of course,” Glimmer replied. “They would have been good to move troops through rougher terrain where your tanks and transports would get stuck.”

“Ah, so in case you needed to evacuate Bright Moon and had not enough skiffs.”

“Yes.”

“Got it!” Bow announced. “So… Hm… that’s a lot of horses. Oh. That includes the horses Swift Wind brought in.”

“But that doesn’t tell us how many are left,” Adora pointed out.

Bow smiled again. “Well, if we use Bright Moon as a baseline…”

“Can we use it as a baseline?” Catra interrupted him. “The Scorpion Kingdom doesn’t have many horses, I bet. And I don’t think the Kingdom of Snows or Salienas have many horses, either.

Bow frowned in return. “It would be a conservative estimate, I think.”

“A wild-ass guess. Got it.” Catra nodded with a smirk.

“It’s the best we have,” Glimmer spat. She tapped a few keys on her tablet, still scowling. “So, all things considered… we could be dealing with a few hundred thousand horses on Etheria.”

That was… a lot. Or was it? “How many horses are on Earth?” Adora asked. “Just to get a comparison,” she explained.

Her friends were staring at her. Even Catra.

“Did he say he wanted to ‘liberate’ them too?” Glimmer asked.

He hadn’t. But it wasn’t as if they had talked about that. Adora wasn’t even sure if he knew that there were horses on Earth - wait, he had to know that after talking with SG-1. Right?

*****

“So… we’ve got people wanting their own planet, without magical princesses to rule them, and a magical flying horse - unicorn - running an underground railroad for runaway horses.”

The Colonel, lying on the couch in their room, didn’t sound as amused as Samantha Carter would have expected, given the situation on Etheria. No comment about ‘ripping off Earth history’ or about former bandits ‘founding space Australia’. He seemed to be treating the potential problem with the seriousness it deserved - for a change. She nodded. “Yes, sir.”

“Solving that will be a little tricky.”

“I do not see the problem,” Teal’c commented. “According to our allies’ best estimates, and supported by Captain Carter’s observations, those people are deserters from a vanquished enemy army who were too craven to take up arms when their planet was under attack. The Princess Alliance does not owe them anything.”

“Yeah, well… obviously, the magical princesses don’t see things as simple as that, Teal’c,” the Colonel replied.

Teal’c inclined his head, acknowledging the point.

“And what do you think about Swift Wind’s, ah, crusade?” Daniel asked.

“I respect his decision to fight to free his brethren.”

“Ah…” The Colonel looked surprised. “We’re talking about horses, not people.”

“Exactly.” Teal’c’s face showed a hint of a smile.

“But…” The Colonel fell silent with a pout. “Were you pulling my leg?”

And the hint vanished. “No, Colonel O’Neill.” Once more, Teal’c nodded. “I do not think that Swift Wind, having been born as a horse, would care whether or not others consider horses as more than animals.”

“Ah… Good point.”

And Teal’c would empathise with the idea of freeing your enslaved brethren.

“Yes,” Daniel agreed. “His, ah, unique history would ensure that he has a different view of the whole situation. And it would be quite, ah, callous, I would say, and perhaps naive and shortsighted as well, to expect him to treat horses as mere animals - he is likely to feel a kinship with them despite their lack

of sapience. Of course, since he is a horse of sorts, that's quite justified."

"Yeah, I think we all realised that when we heard about his crusade to free his brothers and sisters from bondage," the Colonel pointed out in a dry voice.

Daniel blushed slightly. "Well, yes, I was just agreeing with Teal'c."

"Indeed."

"Yeah, yeah. But just because he thinks horses are people doesn't mean everyone will agree with him. And that's the problem," the Colonel said.

Daniel blinked. "What do you mean?"

"We have millions of horses on Earth," the Colonel explained. "Some people even eat them."

"Oh. I didn't… How didn't I think of that?" Daniel looked aghast. "He must think we are cannibals - using the more colloquial definition of a cannibal, of course, since, strictly speaking, cannibalism is defined as eating your own species, not merely other sapient beings."

"I doubt that Swift Wind will care about such word mincing."

Sam nodded in agreement with Teal'c.

"But the real question isn't what our magical flying unicorn is going to do, but what the princesses are going to do." The Colonel was looking at her, Sam realised.

"That wasn't a topic that came up while I was working on the Stargate with Entrapta, sir," she told him.

"I expected that, seeing as everyone seems to have been blindsided by the horse crusader." He was still looking at her. Why would… Ah.

Sam narrowed her eyes. “Entrapta is a brilliant scientist, but she is rarely interested in such political questions,” she pointed out. She wasn’t going to use Entrapta as a source of information about the internal discussions of the Princess Alliance.

“Yeah.” He wasn’t pressing the implied suggestion. Good.

“We’ll have to talk to the Princess Alliance about this,” Daniel pointed out the obvious. “This could become a diplomatic catastrophe if the Etherians back his, ah, intentions! And if he uses his *unique* appearance and nature to run a PR campaign…”

“I think he’d have the girl demographic solidly in his corner. Probably even the French ones,” the Colonel commented.

Daniel nodded. “Well, yes, sure, who wouldn’t love to… Oh my God - what if he wants to attend the party?”

Sam froze. That would…

“We’ve never seen him indoors, have we?” the Colonel asked.

“No. But that doesn’t mean he won’t enter buildings. He might actually live in the palace stables,” Daniel said, wincing. “And since everyone here seems to be getting excited about the party, he might want to attend as well.”

“And someone will want to talk to the talking horse, and talking about horses that don’t talk seems the obvious topic to break the ice.” The Colonel looked grim.

Well, he was nominally in charge of the party organisation now.

Sam managed not to smile at the irony, but only because she was still involved as well. “I suggest you breach the subject as soon as possible, sir.”

“Yeah.”

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 30th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"We should just ignore them. We don't owe them anything."

"But Mermista! We can't just ignore them - they're as much victims of the war as anyone else who was displaced. At the very least, we should let them resettle in a more fertile region of Etheria."

This is getting tedious, Catra thought while she munched on a tuna sandwich.

"They don't want to resettle on Etheria - they want a *planet* of their own. If they wanted to farm, they would have returned to the Scorpion Kingdom like the other former Horde soldiers when you put the call out," Glimmer retorted. "And we can't just ignore them sneaking over Bright Moon's borders! They might attempt to seize the gate by force!"

"All six of them?" Mermista scoffed. "Even Emily could handle that by herself."

"Both Emily's offensive and defensive capabilities have been increased significantly," Entrapta spoke up. "Her shield generator should be able to hold out against a prolonged assault with portable weapons, not counting advanced bombs though."

"Not quite my point, but see? We can ignore them."

"But we shouldn't ignore them!" Perfuma protested. "We're better than that."

"And they're kinda our responsibility - well, mine," Scorpia added. "You know, being former Horde soldiers."

Catra swallowed the last bite and snorted. She was a former Horde soldier herself - former Horde leader, actually - but she didn't owe those idiots anything.

“You fulfilled your responsibilities by offering every former Horde soldier a place in your kingdom,” Glimmer told her. “If they don’t want to live there, that’s on them. And the place certainly fits their request for ‘fertile land’ now,” she added with a scoff.

“Well, yeah, but it doesn’t fit their request not to live under a princess,” Catra said. Half the Alliance leadership turned to glare at her, but she shrugged. “I’m just pointing out that they don’t just want fertile land; they want to rule it.”

“They want an entire planet. For what, a few hundred people?” Gimmer shook her head. “And that’s only if we believe their claims. Huntara messaged us that she doubts that they have such a big tribe.”

“And if we give them a planet, others will want one as well,” Mermista said. “Even a few princesses, I bet. More than a few, actually. I’d suggest giving them some desert island no one wants, but they’d turn pirate as soon as they can get a ship.”

Perfuma shook her head. “They would only turn pirate if they have no better alternatives.”

Oh… Catra suppressed a sigh. “Not exactly. Some people want to be raiders, be they pirates or bandits. They don’t want to work because they prefer fighting.”

“You would know, right?” Mermista frowned at her.

Catra raised her eyebrows at her. “I’m a soldier. I’m good at waging war with all that entails. Logistics, tactics, strategy…” Of course, she also was good at raiding since that was part of waging war, but that wouldn’t help her make her point. “They, though, don’t want to fight a war. They just want to plunder what others built.”

“We don’t know that!” Adora protested.

“Does anyone have serious doubts that we’re dealing with a bunch of bandits?” Catra asked.

“They might want to turn over a new leaf,” Perfuma said.

Which meant that even Perfuma thought that they had been bandits. And that meant they could easily return to their old trade, even if they wanted to change. Which Catra doubted.

“And imagine what example we would be setting if we let bandits set up a colony in the galaxy - and then would supply and protect it.” Glimmer shook her head. “What would our allies think?”

“That this is an easy opportunity to exploit?” Catra suggested with a grin. “If we set up a protected colony, they’ll want one as well.” The Americans had been planning to set up a ‘fallback’ colony or something, in case Earth fell, but that had been before they made contact with Etheria. As far as Catra knew, they were now squabbling with the United Nations and NATO over the whole site.

“Yes. And you know how many humans are on Earth - and how many countries they have. Everyone will want a colony if others have one.” Glimmer scoffed. “So, it’s obvious: We have to refuse their demands.” She looked at the others in the room - well, the other princesses, Catra thought.

Most of them nodded, some more reluctantly than others. Perfuma disagreed but didn’t say anything, and Scorpia hugged her.

Well, it looked like they had finally dealt with this problem. Or at least come to a decision - they still had to deal with the bandits themselves.

“OK.” Glimmer nodded, obviously satisfied. “Now that that’s settled, Jack wanted to discuss a few things, mainly Swift Wind.”

Cara saw that Adora tensed and scowled. Swift Wind’s antics were already stressing her lover. If O’Neill added to that…

Adora would do anything for her friend - no one knew this better than Catra herself. But someone had to look out for Adora in return, or the idiot would sacrifice herself to help everyone else.

And that, Catra would never allow. She'd do anything to protect Adora.

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Going Home Part 5

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 30th, 1998 (Earth Time)

"So, how's it going?" Jack O'Neill asked when he took his usual seat, with his team following suit. The fact that he had a usual seat in the meeting chamber of an alliance of monarchs still felt weird. Even more so because they treated him like an equal. Absolute monarchs weren't supposed to do that - they were supposed to huff and puff about upstart or uppity American peasants.

He suppressed a snort at his weird thoughts and focused on the people present. Glimmer was sitting with her elbows on the table, hands folded, looking directly at him. Adora was sitting straight and tense as if she were a junior officer in a meeting with generals and not the most powerful individual in the room. Catra was sitting slightly slumped over and turned to the side - where Adora was sitting. Jack almost expected her to put her leg over the armrest. Bow was sitting like a straight-A student in class, Netossa like any general from the Pentagon Jack had met under similar circumstances, a contrast to the more relaxed Spinnerella. Mermista was propping up her head with one hand, seemingly bored… Yeah, he had meetings like that before.

"So, you wanted to talk to us?" Glimmer spoke up before he could finish assessing everyone else.

"Yep." He nodded. "Although I have to state beforehand that I'm not speaking for the Air Force, the United States, Earth etc." He saw Daniel relax a bit and had to suppress another snort - as if his friend had any right to complain about potential diplomatic misunderstandings given his own history!

"You're just here as a friend, yes." Glimmer nodded.

"Yes." Jack smiled. "And as a friend, I am a bit concerned about the whole horse business."

“So are we,” Glimmer said.

Adora looked guilty, Jack noticed. And Catra was glaring at him as if that was his fault. Well, it wasn’t. Whatever the problem was was on the Etherians. But he better got straight to the point. “Yeah, I bet. Anyway, I - we - were wondering what you were doing about it, if you were planning to do anything about it, seeing as Earth also has horses.” He smiled. “And a lot of them. Some people on Earth even eat horses.” That made everyone wince, Jack noticed. “I guess you didn’t know that.”

“I think we heard something about it but forgot,” Catra said, sighing. She was sitting straight, now. No more posturing.

“That… complicates matters,” Glimmer said while she rubbed the bridge of her nose.

“You eat horses?” Perfuma asked.

“So did the Horde,” Catra said. “When we could catch them, remember?” She looked at Scorpia.

“Right.” Scorpia nodded. “Force Captains always got their cut, yes, if anyone caught an animal.”

“What’s wrong with eating animals?” Frosta asked with a frown. “First, you’ve got something against hunting seals for their pelts; now we shouldn’t eat game and fish either?”

“No one’s saying not to eat animals,” Glimmer spoke up. “But horses are a special case since Swift Wind used to be a horse.”

“I think he still qualifies as a horse,” Bow said. “Just a… magical variant?”

“I think the wings and horn kind of contradict that,” Jack retorted.

“Many animals of the same species have drastically different appearances. Just think how many different breeds of dogs exist,”

Daniel cut in. “I would say his sapience is more important. And his ability to talk.”

“Well, yes, but those are magical changes,” Bow said. “We don’t actually know how extensive those changes are.”

“He might not be a new species - we would need to test his DNA for that,” Entrapta added. “And then we would have to compare it to the data from Alpha.”

Ah, the research base they had discovered on one of the moons. Where the Ancients had been playing God. Jack pressed his lips together at the thought. And he wasn’t thinking about being related to them. Not at all!

“Ah. So, you don’t know if he can have fertile offspring with horses,” Daniel said, nodding.

That triggered another row of grimaces.

“Daniel!” Jack hissed, as Glimmer pointedly said: “No, we haven’t asked if he’s, ah, trying.”

His friend actually blushed. “Oh, I’m sorry - I’m really sorry. I didn’t think…”

Jack swallowed the ‘no, you really didn’t’ he had on the tip of his tongue and shook his head. “Anyway, does it matter if he actually is a horse, as long as he thinks he is?”

“Well, if he’s operating from faulty data, he might change his plans once he knows the truth,” Entrapta said. “Provided he is a different species, of course.”

“I don’t think he, ah, thinks like that,” Adora spoke up. “Besides, his parents were horses. And he might have siblings he never met. That they aren’t as smart as he is doesn’t matter to him.”

“Indeed,” Teal’c commented with a nod. “I doubt he will stray from his chosen course of action whether or not his species

changed."

"Yep." Jack thought so as well. It would have been a neat solution, but things rarely worked out like that. "So, what are you going to do about the whole horse slavery and cannibalism thing? And I know it *technically* isn't cannibalism," he added before Daniel or Entrapta could say something.

"We're still trying to figure that out," Bow replied. "Oh, by the way, do you know how many horses are on Earth?"

Jack looked at Carter, but she shook her head. Daniel looked lost as well, and he knew better than to expect Teal'c to know such a thing. "I'll have to ask Stargate Command next time they dial in," he said. "That should be… in half an hour." Nice timing. But they would wonder why he was asking such a thing.

He wasn't looking forward to explaining the reason.

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"...and so, if Swift Wind managed to convince everyone on Earth to free all horses, you'd be stuck with over fifty million horses to deal with - and many of them rely on human caretakers."

Adora was trying to listen to Daniel's explanation, but it was difficult. She still had trouble imagining so many horses. That was more than Etheria's population! There was no way, not even if everyone pitched in, that they could put them all to pasture in Bright Moon. Or anywhere else.

"What do you mean, they rely on human caretakers?" Scorpia asked.

"Ah…" Daniel shifted his notes around. "Over the centuries - millennia - of domestication, many horses were bred for specialised purposes, which means that for them, adapting to living in the wilderness without humans to feed, protect and nurse them is difficult or even impossible. And, of course, some horses of a breed that could survive in the wilderness might have

difficulties adapting to a life without human contact, though that remains to be seen - there are multiple examples of wild populations developing from horses that escaped their owners, the most famous probably being the mustangs of North America. But the odds of those horses bred to race, or for pulling heavy loads, or the miniature breeds, doing well in the wild are not very good."

Oh. So, it was even worse than Adora had thought. Even if everyone agreed to set the horses free - and she was aware that was not likely - many horses would die as a result.

"But enough - more than enough, I think - would survive to cause an ecological catastrophe in the areas they populated," Perfuma said, shaking her head and leaning against Scorpia, who had her arm wrapped around her. "I can create areas suited for horses by changing the plantlife in the region, but the sheer scale of it… and, of course, I can't change the local climate, so, even with adaptive plants, there are limits - not to mention that changing plants like that can cause an ecological catastrophe by themselves if they start displacing other plants, so…" She trailed off with an unhappy expression.

"...so, even if your friend managed the impossible and got all horses freed, he'd end up dooming millions of them," Jack finished for her with a wry smile.

"And keeping those horses that couldn't survive without humans in human hands… well, I don't think that too many people would want to take care of horses for free if they couldn't ride them or put them to work," Glimmer said. "And paying them would cost a lot of money."

"Well, some activists would volunteer, but I'm not sure there would be enough," Daniel said. "Unless they can ride the horses in exchange. I think more would agree to such a deal."

Would Swift Wind agree to that? Or would he still see it as enslavement?

Before Adora could say anything, Teal'c spoke up: "If they have been altered so they cannot live free any more, would not taking care of them be the duty of those who have owned them and profited from them?"

"We're still talking about animals, Teal'c," Jack said with a slight frown. "They aren't people."

Teal'c nodded slowly. "They are not - but neither is Swift Wind."

"But he's intelligent. Horses aren't," Jack retorted.

"Sapient," Daniel said.

"Whatever. In any case, horses aren't people, and we can't expect everyone to treat them like people," Jack said.

"You don't have to treat them like people in order to not, ah, own or eat them," Daniel said. "Many Indians consider cows sacred, for example, and would not eat them. I think stopping the butchering and eating of horses might not be impossible."

"Just nearly so. If the French decide that eating horses is, like eating frogs, a core part of their culture…" Jack scoffed.

"Jack!" Daniel frowned. "That's a stereotype! Besides, I think many would have second thoughts about eating horses if they knew that there is a sapient horse."

"In his presence, sure, kind of awkward, but he can't be everywhere - there's only one of him," Jack pointed out.

It was a little weird to see them argue about Swift Wind and horses when this was all her fault. But Adora didn't know how to solve this. Not without hurting Swift Wind.

"Well, here's one of him now - but could there be more?" Daniel asked.

“We don’t know if he can have kids with normal horses. Or wants to,” Catra said. “Do you want to ask him?” She looked at Daniel, who grimaced in return.

And then everyone was looking at her, Adora realised.

“If Swift Wind can breed with normal horses, that would certainly change the situation, I think. Right?” Entrapta asked, cocking her head.

“How so?” Mermista asked,

“Well, with the advantages sapience, flight and magic grant them, they could replace horses. Eventually. Although it would take a very long time,” Entrapta replied. “But more importantly, they were the same species, just with different levels of intelligence.”

“The horses would still be animals,” Jack insisted.

“But we don’t treat humans as animals even if they aren’t smarter than, say, a smart ape,” Daniel pointed out.

Jack opened his mouth, then closed it again. “But he wasn’t born that way - he was made that way!” he said after a moment.

“So were half the people on Etheria.” Catra shrugged. “Just saying - I won’t start a crusade to free cats any time soon, don’t worry,” she added with a grin aimed at Adora.

But it wasn’t funny. Adora would have to ask Swift Wind about his… well, his biology. And family matters. She’d rather deal with a Goa’uld or Horde attack.

But this was all her fault - sort of. Swift Wind wasn’t a mistake or something. In any case, he was her responsibility. She wouldn’t run from it. She nodded.

But, once again, before she could say something, someone else spoke up. Daniel, this time. And he was addressing her. “So, just,

well, it's kind of related, so… since you created him, could you create more of him?"

Adora was at a loss for words again. Create more like Swift Wind? Alter more horses?

"Daniel, we shouldn't encourage people to play God," Jack said.

"It wouldn't be playing God!" Daniel protested. Then he frowned. "Well, not any more, in a sense, than what the Ancients did on Etheria."

And Adora was a First One. "Oh, no!" she blurted out. "I am acting like my ancestors!"

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Samantha Carter winced when she saw Adora's face fall. That hadn't been…

"That's not true!" Glimmer snapped. "They experimented with people - and tried to destroy Etheria to take out Horde Prime - but you just wanted to activate your sword. You didn't want to experiment and create Swift Wind."

"Yes. So don't try to make it sound as if she did!" Catra sneered at Daniel. "That's not even remotely the same."

Daniel looked struck. "I'm sorry, I didn't mean it like that. I just… I just wanted to point out that it's not playing God." He set his jaw. "But I think we do need to know what exactly happened to Swift Wind. And, ah, what the potential consequences could be."

Meaning, whether or not he would have offspring, Sam translated in her mind.

"I can't really reproduce what I did since I didn't know what I was doing," Adora replied. "And I don't… I don't *want* to repeat it." She pressed her lips together.

She didn't elaborate on her reasons for the refusal, and Sam couldn't tell if Adora was refusing because she felt it had been a mistake or if she didn't want to risk something going wrong - or acting like the Ancients who had experimented on Etheria's people. Probably a mixture of all three.

"But what if Swift Wind feels lonely as the only one of his kind?" Perfuma asked. "What if he asks to have companions? An actual species?" She looked at Entrapta. "Assuming he isn't a member of the horse species any more."

Entrapta closed her mouth and cocked her head sideways, nose scrunched. "Uh… Experimenting with animals is fine, right?"

"That is somewhat controversial, with regard to horses at least," Sam told her.

"That complicates things," Entrapta said.

"I don't know if having more like Swift Wind around would make things easier," the Colonel commented.

"Well, he might be too busy dealing with others of his kind to bother with freeing all the horses?" Daniel suggested.

"That's not how it works." Adora shook her head. "You don't stop doing what you think is right because there are more people and things to do."

Catra looked like she disagreed, but the catwoman didn't say anything - although her frown had deepened, Sam noticed.

And Daniel was being stubborn. "Well, I still think we need to know if there will be more of his kind in the future."

"Yes." Adora nodded. "But that depends on what he wants - we can't decide things for him."

"But he is trying to decide for us how we should treat horses," Glimmer retorted.

“He’s trying to do what he thinks is right,” Adora told her. “And we haven’t told him to stop, have we?”

King Micah grimaced. “Well… no.”

“Quite the contrary,” Glimmer commented dryly with a glance at her father.

“I’ll talk to him,” Adora said, sighing. “I’ll explain our concerns, but…” She shrugged.

Entrapta nodded in obvious agreement. “Until we have more data, we can’t make a sound decision. So we need more data!”

“Yes.” Glimmer sighed. “Well, at least we decided how to handle the colonists.” She turned her head to look at the Colonel. “Unless similar requests are coming up on Earth.”

He smiled wryly. “I am sure a lot of people wish to set up colonies of their own, but as far as I know, there hasn’t been anything beyond the proposal stage - and nothing that is even close to being approved.”

“Not even the, what did you call it, the Alpha Site?” Bow asked. “Which I hope no one will confuse with Alpha here.”

“Well, that was a sort of emergency project. Its fate is now a point of discussion between the United States, the United Nations and our allies on Earth,” the Colonel deflected. “And above my pay grade,” he added.

Sam winced again. It had been a logical response to their past situation, ensuring that there was a failsafe plan should the Goa’uld conquer Earth, to have a fall-back position from which they could rebuild. But the rest of the world saw it as the United States attempting to save their own culture and leaving the rest of the world to be destroyed. Which, if Sam was honest, was exactly how it would have worked out, due to the secrecy that had been maintained at the time.

"We'll have to talk about colonies with the Alliance as well. And with the United Nations," Glimmer said. "Before people make concrete plans - or go off on their own."

It was already too late for the former; Sam was aware of that. And the latter… what would Stargate Command do if the Russians or the Chinese wanted to set up a colony? Stop them? What if the United Nations voted for starting a colony?

She was very glad that she wouldn't have to make such decisions. She was just a scientist. And, she reminded herself as everyone was getting up, she had work to do at the Stargate - they were falling behind schedule because of this meeting. Well, behind the revised schedule; they were still ahead of the original schedule.

Still, it would be good to do some productive work instead of… meetings like this. Not that they weren't important, of course - quite the contrary. But Sam was a scientist, not a diplomat or politician.

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Gate Area, Outside Bright Moon, Etheria, December 30th, 1998 (Earth Time)

The gate site really looked like a Horde base now. Catra had known it would, of course - she had been involved in the planning stage and had double-checked the layout. But to see it up close, finished, the familiar pre-fabricated walls and bunkers surrounding her… It didn't quite raise her hackles, but it brought back memories she'd rather forget. Between the bots and the fortifications, it *felt* like a Horde base, despite Bright Moon soldiers manning the walls and patrolling the perimeter.

"I feel like we should be sneaking around here," Bow commented near her. She turned her head to glance at him, and he winced a little. "Ah, sorry!"

Catra snorted. "Well, if you want to test the guards, feel free. We can find out if Bright Moon's best and brightest are better at

guarding a site than the Horde."

She saw him blink before he laughed. For a moment, he hadn't been sure if she was joking. Good. She liked being a little unpredictable.

"Well, Glimmer picked them personally - they are usually guarding the palace - so…" He shrugged.

"So, they might actually stop a push by bandits." Catra snorted again. "But how well will they be doing if a princess attacks?" She had seen what happened to large numbers of Horde troops and bots under such attacks, and she didn't think Alliance forces were that much better at fighting princesses. If at all - Horde soldiers had been trained to fight the Princess Alliance, after all. At least nominally; actual combat performance hadn't been very impressive for their regular forces.

"Well, how likely is that?" Bow asked.

She shrugged. "You tell me. I wasn't at the meeting with Princess Bee."

"It's Sweet Bee," he corrected her. She cocked her head at him, raising her eyebrows, and he sighed. "Sweet Bee wants access to the gate, but she wouldn't attack us."

"And that's why we're here to check gate security, right." She snorted.

"It's not…" He sighed. "Well, there was some concern since she was once dating Prince Peakablue, who was a member of the first Princess Alliance."

"The scryer, yes. That's why Castaspella is here." Shadow Weaver had claimed that she had countered the prince's powers. And since the Alliance forces hadn't run rings around the Horde - well, not even more than they had done at times - Catra was pretty sure the woman hadn't been lying. But it remained to be seen if Glimmer's aunt could do the same.

“Yes.” Bow shrugged. “Anyway, I don’t think…”

“There she is,” Catra interrupted him, pointing towards the main gate.

“Ah.” Bow checked his pad. “A bit earlier than planned.”

“Let’s go say hello.” Catra was already moving towards the small group entering the base, ears twitching as she tried to listen in to what they were saying.

“...and as you can see, the site is secure. There’s no chance that this will be used to launch an invasion of Etheria,” Glimmer was saying as Catra approached.

The other princess didn’t look impressed, wrinkling her nose and brushing some blonde locks out of her face as she looked around. Her antennas twitched, but Catra didn’t know if that was normal or a sign of tension for her species - the princess’s butterfly wings didn’t move, at least. “It looks as if we’ve been invaded already,” she commented with a sniff. Then she spotted Catra and scowled deeply.

Catra grinned in return before turning to Glimmer. “Base’s up to snuff,” she told her.

“Noted.”

“Seeing you working with former invaders is not exactly filling me with trust in your ability to safeguard the gate,” Sweet Bee said.

Catra shrugged and made sure to smile as innocently as she could. “Ah! Of course, instead, you would trust people who haven’t even had the guts to fight said invaders.”

“Catra!” Bow hissed next to her.

She ignored him and watched as Sweet Bee glowered at her. That had been a solid hit. The closest the princess had come to fighting

the Horde had been dating a former member of the Alliance, after all.

Instead of retorting, Sweet Bee turned to face Glimmer. “My concerns remain. And I am not convinced that this new threat is as dire as you claim. It is a bit too convenient.”

“Convenient?” Glimmer scowled as well.

“You’ve finally defeated the Horde, but instead of dismantling your armies and embracing peace, you meet a new enemy that requires you to build up even more forces for another war. How convenient for you - especially since you’ve also just discovered a gate that connects Etheria to other planets and a First Ones research base that supposedly was the birthplace of our civilisation - on a moon you personally lay claim to and which can only be reached through ships you and your allies control.” Sweet Bee sniffed again.

“What?” Glimmer glared at her. “Are you saying that we made this up to… to dominate Etheria?”

Sweet Bee showed her teeth in return. “All I am saying is that it is a very convenient excuse for keeping your armies ready to fight and taking control of artefacts that, by any right, should be the domain of all of Etheria. And I am not the only one who has made such an observation. Especially since we haven’t seen even one soldier of your enemies.”

Ah, that was their angle. Catra didn’t think it would work out - the Princess Alliance was the supreme military power on Etheria and didn’t have to bow to anyone - but it looked like more trouble was afoot on the diplomatic front. Right when they couldn’t really afford such distractions and in the middle of the Swift Wind mess. And Adora would blame herself for this somehow and feel even guiltier now.

Catra had to suppress the sudden urge to unsheath her claws and hiss at the princess.

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Bright Moon, Etheria, December 30th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill knew this wasn't the best time. Glimmer seemed more than a little stressed, probably from having to deal with flying horses on crusades, bandit raiders and now queen bees all vying for her attention. Carter's report about the visit to the gate site had made it sound as if Catra had been the most diplomatic at the meeting, not counting Bow and the other tech heads, and that said enough about how cordial that visit had been.

But he wasn't sure whether there would be a better time any time soon or when he would be next on Etheria with some time to spare to address this particular little problem. Or not so little. Sure, if he asked Hammond and explained, he probably would get permission for a personal trip to Etheria, but if anything leaked… Jack could endure a lot, had endured a lot, for his country - or for Earth, now - but he could do without the endless jokes he knew this would spawn.

So it was time to bite the bullet. Taking a deep breath, he approached the door to Glimmer's office and nodded at the guards. "Hi. Is the queen free for a short talk before dinner?"

"We'll check," the female guard said before turning away and knocking on the door. After a moment, she opened the door and slipped inside. Jack hadn't heard any answer or command to enter, so the knocking was probably just to give Glimmer a few seconds to put down what she was doing.

The door closed behind the guard, leaving him waiting with the other guard, a male one, pretty young, who looked completely focused on his job. Which begged for some comments and questions, like how it felt to guard a queen who could probably wipe the floor with her entire army.

But Jack restrained himself. Pissing off the grunts of your allies was not a smart idea. Especially if you were the junior partner in

the alliance.

And if you needed a favour. A personal favour. Sure, it would also benefit the Alliance, but it still felt like Jack was abusing his friendship and position for personal gains.

The door swung open again, and the female appeared. “The Queen will see you now.”

Glimmer was at her desk - which, even if it was of a size that would give the worst Earth CEO a case of envy, looked small in the room and was covered with files and letters and whatnot - and as soon as the door closed, she sighed. “Hi, Jack. Don’t tell me there’s another crisis to deal with, please.”

Yep, she was stressed - and expecting another crisis. Jack shook his head. “No crisis. None that I’d know of, at least. Just a small little personal request.” Here goes nothing, he thought. Then, taking a deep breath and grimacing, he said: “I need some magic help.”

Glimmer’s eyebrows rose. “Oh?”

Sighing, Jack started to explain.

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“...and that’s about it,” Jack O’Neill finished his explanation for the second time in ten minutes. “Glimmer said you might be able to help me.” If anyone could.

Castaspella frowned a little as she put her elbows on her desk - which was half the size of Glimmer’s and only half-covered in paper and what seemed to be parchment. “I see. You wish to prevent anyone from using your genetic material to create unwanted children.”

“Yes. No children at all without my permission, basically,” Jack said. It was best to make that clear in case someone might think as long as one parent wanted the child, it was OK.

“Yes.” She nodded. “It is understandable, given your situation, though more than a little unusual for Etheria.”

“It’s also unusual for Earth.” He grinned.

She smiled in return. “So I heard. Contraceptives and abortions are the usual means to deal with unwanted pregnancies, though that wouldn’t help you with your problem. And cloning is a very new technology - we haven’t had to deal with such issues before we encountered Horde Prime. But I can think of a few ways how this could be addressed. Maybe a modification of a sealing spell… though the side effects would need to be addressed, of course, or the results might turn out to be quite unpleasant.” She tilted her head. “And that would be a shame.”

Jack pressed his lips together. The woman sounded a little too flippant - and a little too interested, both in his problem and maybe in himself, though he could be mistaken about the later part. As anyone in Stargate Command knew, and Daniel loved to explain, alien cultures had different social cues, so you couldn’t be sure you weren’t misinterpreting the subtext of a conversation unless you asked. And ‘hey, do you think I am attractive? I am just checking if I am reading you correctly; I am not interested in you, OK?’ was the last thing he wanted to ask a witch. Hell hath no fury like a woman scorned and all.

“But I’ll have to discuss this with my colleagues in Mystacore. And I’ll have to examine you, of course, in case your ancestry has a mythical part to it that might affect a spell.” She smiled widely.

Definitely too eager, Jack thought. Maybe he should have gone to Entrapta instead. Even though that meant Carter would hear about it practically at once.

But the die was cast.

“So, if you would stand up? This won’t take long.” She gestured to the round carpet in the middle of her room.

‘Don’t make any jokes about undressing for the examination,’ Jack told himself, very firmly, as he walked over. He really couldn’t afford any misunderstandings.

*****

“Swift Wind? Yes, I’ve seen him arrive. He’s in the palace stables - well, former palace stables - I think.”

“Thank you.” Adora forced herself to smile at the guard before she turned away and started walking.

‘Former stables’. She knew why there were no horses there any more. The palace horses had been the first herd Swift Wind had taken to pasture. And Bright Moon’s people had let him do it because they thought Adora supported it. Which she didn’t - well, not unconditionally. She could understand that Swift Wind wanted to free horses since he was a horse. Sort of. But horses weren’t intelligent - not sapient. They were animals, not people. On the other hand, if a human got brain damage, did they stop being human and become an animal? Was there a line, a point where you’d stop being human because you were too dumb?

She didn’t think that was how it worked. Of course, a horse was different - a horse had never been sapient. But what if a human was born with brain damage? They were still a human, weren’t they? And while Swift Wind had been a normal horse, if he suffered brain damage, Adora would do what she could to heal him. Once sapient, always sapient, even if you were not any more? It seemed a bit unfair to treat humans like that.

And what if Adora could repeat what she had done to Swift Wind? Wouldn’t all horses then have the potential to be sapient? And would it be right to keep them from becoming sapient? From becoming a person? It didn’t seem fair to keep people - well, potential people - from ‘achieving their potential’.

On the other hand, even if Adora managed to discover how to repeat what she had done to Swift Wind, she wouldn’t have the

time to do that to every horse. There were over fifty million horses on Earth. And the people on many planets occupied by the Goa'uld had horses as well because they weren't allowed more advanced technology and couldn't use magic. There was no way she could, ah, change all of them even if she did nothing but that.

But just because she couldn't help everyone didn't mean she shouldn't help anyone. That wasn't right either. You had to help those you could.

She bit her lower lip as she remembered Catra telling her that sacrificing her life for others wasn't right either.

This was so complicated! She had told the others she'd talk to Swift Wind, but she had no idea what to say! She was such a failure! She was…

"Hey, Adora!"

She gasped and turned. That hadn't been Catra, but Swift Wind. And there he was, smiling at her from the other end of the courtyard she was walking through. "Swift Wind." Once again, she forced herself to smile. "How are you?"

"I am doing great!" her friend pranced a little, wings flapping once. "You've returned! Horses are being set free! And we're about to fight to save the galaxy and free more slaves - a worthy cause indeed!"

Adora managed not to wince. She didn't want to dampen his spirit - and she had been away for months, so that was her fault as well - but… But she had to do this, and she would do this. "Speaking of horses…" she trailed off as she approached him.

"Yes?" He moved closer to her, turning to present his side so she could mount him.

Adora was tempted, but… this wasn't a talk they could have while flying. And she had to have this talk. If only… She sighed and

shook her head. “We can fly later. There’s something I need to… ask you.”

“Oh? Ask away!” He was still beaming at her.

Oh, this was… embarrassing. And not just because she didn’t know what she had done. She looked around. “Let’s head outside.” They would best talk about this where people couldn’t stumble upon them.

“Alright.” He looked a little confused but nodded, and they walked out of the courtyard and towards the closest gate.

The guards there nodded and let them through without being asked to. And they didn’t ask why Swift Wind wasn’t flying. But would they wonder? Adora didn’t know.

Outside, she pointed at the closest field. “Let’s go there.”

“Oh, yes! The gardeners sowed the tastiest grass there!”

Ah. And didn’t that sound… well, no, enjoying a tasty meal was perfectly normal for all people. Especially if you had been raised in the Horde. Why wouldn’t a horse enjoy a special meal, either?

The short walk was really short. Shorter than Adora had expected. And now she had no excuses any more. It was time to talk.

“So…” She smiled at her friend. “It’s a bit of a sensitive question, so if you don’t want to answer, you don’t have to. OK?”

“Of course! We’re friends, after all.”

“Yes.” She took a deep breath. “So, ah, I was curious - well, it’s not as if I thought long about it, but it came up in conversation, kinda, so…” She forced herself to keep smiling widely. “And it’s a bit weird for me, since I was responsible, but I don’t really know how it happened, so I don’t know what happened exactly, so… Do you know if you can have children?”

Swift Wind blinked and didn't answer right away.

Adora didn't know if that was a good sign.

"Well…" Swift Wind sounded less like… less like himself than usual. Less sure, less… enthusiastic. "I don't know," he said.

"Oh." That… What did that mean, actually? That he had never… or that he had tried, but wasn't sure, or…

He turned to look away. "It's… Do you know the feeling when everyone's doing something, everyone wants to do it, and you don't understand why they want it so much?"

"Uh…" Adora actually didn't. Was that like food? Catra loved fish, but Adora understood that. She didn't love fish as much as her lover - she doubted anyone she knew did - but she had her own favourite food. A lot, actually.

Fortunately, Swift Wind continued, watching the horizon. "So, most horses, except for those who were mutilated, get those urges. The mares come up to the stallions, nuzzle them and… well, it might take some time, but the stallion generally wants it to, you know? And it's not just that; they nuzzle and cosy up and such. But it's all *about* that." He sighed, still looking at the horizon. "And I don't get that. I mean, it's nice to be close, cosy up, but… I don't really want to do the rest. Or, rather, It's not that I would hate to do it - I just don't feel the urge to do it or any… desire to do it. And it feels a little weird, you know?"

Adora didn't. But she nodded anyway. "Yes," she lied.

"Exactly! So, I usually just avoid the mares if they're like that. And the stallions, since they get weird and aggressive."

"Ah."

"But that's normal - I mean, you wouldn't like it if people watched you, ah, do it with Catra, right? You'd want some privacy." He was

looking at her, but he still seemed a bit… less sure of himself. Or full of himself, a small voice in her mind added.

"Oh, yes," she agreed, nodding emphatically.

"And it's not as if I was mutilated," he went on. "I checked."

"Ah." She didn't have to know that. Well, she did, probably, but it was… how do you ask a friend if they still had, ah, all their parts? When it had happened, Adora hadn't known about geldings, and she hadn't really wanted to know if Swift Wind had been a stallion before her magic hit him or if she had healed him at the same time… although that might be important. Not important enough to ask now, though. Not when he seemed so vulnerable. "I see," she added.

"Yes. So, I don't know if I can have children."

And he didn't sound as if he wanted to find out. Adora nodded again.

"It's… I guess it would be nice to have more like me, but…" He sighed again. "I'm not sure I am ready. And having children is a huge commitment. We're about to fight a war, aren't we?"

"Yes."

"And there are so many horses left to free."

Adora suppressed a grimace. "About that…" She trailed off - this wasn't the moment - but it was too late.

He cocked his head and looked at her. "Yes?"

"There might be too many horses to have them run around free," she said. "And some might not be able to live free."

"What?"

She wanted to curse herself. Why hadn't she kept her mouth shut? Swift Wind was talking about something incredibly sensitive, and she was… But she was committed now. "Some horse breeds are not suited for the wilderness. They can't find enough food on their own. Or they are too fragile to survive without, ah, medical assistance. They depend on humans."

"I know. But they're that way because humans made them so. So, they should take responsibility and care for them."

Ah. What could she say to that? "Like they were doing?"

He frowned. "They were only doing it because the horses were useful for them! And only as long as they could work! Forcing someone to work for you is slavery!"

"But many love horses," Adora said. "They don't need them for work - they just love to ride them." She had seen enough on Earth to know that.

"That's…" He frowned again. "I guess that's OK. But only if they want to be ridden."

"Well, you like me to ride you, don't you?"

"Well, I am your loyal steed:" He posed, one hoof raised, neck straight and head bent at an angle, with his wings flaring. "And we share a sacred bond."

"Yes, we do." She smiled.

"But will every horse find a worthy rider?" He frowned again. "You said there were too many to run free."

"Ah." She sighed. "There are more horses on Earth than there are people on Etheria."

He blinked. "Really? But…"

She nodded. “We checked.” Sort of. Jack and his friends had checked.

“Wow. But there are also more people on Earth than on Etheria, right?”

“Yes. And the land available is limited.” That was… well, kind of true. The land was being used for other things, mostly. As far as she knew.

“But if they can feed and keep so many horses, then there has to be enough land for them.”

“Yes. But not enough land to just… roam and be free. Not enough good land.” Adora shrugged with a forced smile, remembering the claims from the bandits. “Or so I’ve heard.”

“I’ll have to look into that.” His vulnerability was gone - now he looked determined again. “Maybe when we attend the party. Do they have horses there?”

Oh… “It’s underground,” she said. “In a huge bunker. There are no horses nearby.”

“Oh. Well, we can travel afterwards, can’t we? Once the Stargate is repaired?”

“Well, yes, but the Stargate on Earth is also underground, and they’re going to move it.” This wasn’t where she had wanted this conversation to go. Stargate Command wouldn’t be happy. “And there’s another thing.”

“Yes?”

“Can you talk to horses? Like we talk?”

He snorted. “They can’t talk like we talk.”

She pouted a little. “You know what I mean.”

“Yes.” He looked at the field. “They’re not… they aren’t like me, you know.”

“Yes.”

“They’re… simpler. But I remember what it was like, being like them. So I can understand them. And I know how to make them understand me.”

“Ah.” That was… well, it explained a few things.

But it didn’t make things easier.

*****

Going Home Part 6

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 30th, 1998 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter was feeling good when she returned to their quarters in the palace. They had made great progress at the Stargate. If everything else went well, they would have it operating tomorrow. Just in time to return to Earth for the New Year. Unfortunately, the party wasn't on New Year's Eve, or Sam might have been tempted to tell Entrapta that they needed to take an extra day or two to test the gate…

"Hi, Sam!" Daniel greeted her from behind the stack of tomes he had borrowed from the palace archives.

Teal'c nodded at her without rising from his meditative position.

And the Colonel…

"Jack had to talk to Glimmer, I think," Daniel told her. "He's been gone for… two hours?" Daniel blinked at his watch. "Wow! Time flies."

Two hours? That was a long time for a meeting with Glimmer. It must be important, then. But… "He didn't ask you to come with him?" she asked.

"What?" Daniel looked up from his notes. "No. Why?"

Because if whatever the Colonel wanted to talk about with Glimmer was so important as to take two hours would be important enough to drag Daniel with them for his insight.

Or Sam herself, she added, clenching her teeth a little. Sure, she was doing crucial work at the Stargate, but she was also an officer in the Air Force and the Colonel's Second-in-command; she would have expected to be consulted or informed at least.

"Did he tell you what it was about?"

"No…" Daniel frowned. "Come to think of it, he said it was a minor thing when I asked if he needed me to come along."

Oh? This was getting more and more suspicious. Either the Colonel was hiding something, or something had happened that had delayed him. Sam wasn't quite sure what would be worse. "Maybe we should look for him. It's almost dinner time," she said. She didn't bother with using the radio; it didn't work inside the palace, and the Colonel hadn't a communicator tapping into the Etheran commnet. Which was an oversight they needed to correct, actually.

"Do you think something happened to him?" Daniel asked, standing up again.

"Do you suspect enemy action?" Teal'c rose gracefully and grabbed his staff weapon.

Apparently, she couldn't fool her friends. Sam shook her head. "I'm sure it's nothing like that." She certainly hoped so. But they knew from Glimmer's own stories that the palace wasn't as safe as it should be - or should have been; they had improved the security after the war. Still…

The door opened, interrupting her thoughts.

"You didn't have to walk me back to my room," the Colonel said as he entered. And behind him…

"But I wanted to," Castaspella said, smiling. "And it was the least I could do for you."

"Well, don't… Ah. Already finished at the Stargate, Carter? What's the status of it?" The Colonel cocked his head as he looked at her.

But he was a bit too quick to ask for a report. And with an outsider in the room and the door open? He was hiding something.

"Ah, hello, Captain Carter. Daniel. Teal'c." The sorceress smiled at them all. But she stayed at the door. Next to the Colonel. And she turned back to him. "I'll see you at dinner. And afterwards."

"Yeah, sure." He nodded quickly. "And, ah, thanks."

"Oh, I should thank you. For this opportunity."

What opportunity? Sam almost glared at the Colonel as the woman left and the door closed. But you didn't do that to your commanding officer. Nor did you demand an explanation in such a situation.

"What's going on, Jack?" Fortunately, Daniel was as curious as Sam was.

"Oh, nothing. I just had some questions about magic, and Glimmer referred me to Castaspella." The Colonel shrugged.

"Oh?" Daniel cocked his head to the side. "What kind of questions?"

"The kind of questions that are *private*," the Colonel replied with a frown. "Which I'm not going to talk about." He sounded quite firm.

Daniel recoiled a little at the answer - and probably at the tone as well. "Oh, sure…"

Sam nodded. The Colonel didn't want to talk about whatever this was about. That meant that pushing him would not only be rude but pointless as well.

But it also meant that she really wanted to know what was going on. For… several reasons. The Colonel wasn't afraid of magic, but he didn't like it either, so whatever made him seek the advice of a sorceress had to be important. Important enough for his second-in-command to be informed.

And the obvious interest Castaspella had shown… Sam *really* wanted to know if that interest was directed at whatever this was

about - or at the Colonel.

*****

O'Neill had made Sam mad. Catra was sure of that. Sam wasn't glaring at him, but she was… a little distant, yet paying close attention to him during dinner. And to Castaspella. Who, in turn, was talking to the Colonel quite a bit more than usual, although mostly about magic. Which was kind of odd for the human. She was sitting across him on the table as well, now that Catra thought of it - not quite as close to Micah and Glimmer as usual.

"It's jealousy, then," Catra whispered.

"Hm?"

Catra turned her head and grinned at Adora. "Sam's jealous of Castaspella."

"What?" Her lover blinked, then stared at Sam and Castaspella. Three. Two. One. "But… is Castaspella even interested in Jack?"

Catra shrugged. "Ask Glimmer?" She didn't think the sorceress was actually interested in O'Neill that way, but stranger things had happened.

"But…" Adora shook her head. "Should we talk to her?"

"Sam? Or Castaspella?" Catra asked.

"Uh…" Adora winced. "Either would be embarrassing if we're wrong."

"Yes." Catra didn't think she was wrong, but it was also funnier to just let things go on. Maybe this would be the push that Sam obviously needed to admit she was in love with her commander.

She tilted her ears a little to better listen to Castaspella and O'Neill, but Castaspella was still talking about how great magic was. And how versatile a sorceress could be. It sounded almost as

if she was advertising Mystacore, but she should already know that Earth was the last planet where sorcerers needed advertising - the humans, at least those countries not ruled by lunatics, wanted anyone able to work magic they could get.

And O'Neill, for all he didn't like magic, was far too smart and pragmatic to scorn magic used by allies. So, why was he looking like he would rather be fighting off a Goa'uld attack? Because of Sam? Possible.

But before Catra could think of a way to get to the bottom of this without making anyone mad at her - or not too mad at her - Glimmer spoke up. "So, we might need to either ask a Tok'ra to visit Etheria or get a Goa'uld prisoner for a while. It seems there are a number of princesses who not only fail to understand the danger we face but doubt that the Goa'uld are real."

"Yes, I heard." O'Neill was very quick to respond - maybe a bit too quick. He was hiding something.

But everyone was now chiming in.

"They are fools, and we shouldn't even give them the time of the day, much less risk a Goa'uld escaping, just because they are being stupid," Mermista said.

"We should show them what we are facing if only so they'll be on the lookout for Goa'uld infiltrators," Netossa objected. "We can't afford any kingdom being taken over like that - if they gain a foothold…"

Spinnerella, of course, nodded in agreement.

"How would they manage that?" Glimmer retorted. "We control the gate."

"But if we introduce the rest of Etheria to the Goa'uld - or the Tok'ta - some might seek them out," Perfuma said. "And they might push even more for sharing access to the gate."

“We should put it into space!” Entrapta suggested. “We control access to space! And while there are some technical hurdles to overcome, we already know it’s possible since the Goa’uld use gates on their ships. We could also build a space station - maybe we could build it inside Adora’s plant!”

“It’s not my plant.”

“You made it.”

“I had to use the magic power before something went wrong. More wrong.”

“Still yours.”

“I don’t think we should put the gate into orbit,” Glimmer said. “We can’t effectively use our powers there.”

“Or spells,” Castaspella added.

“And I think some of the princesses who are currently trusting us might grow a bit more suspicious - it’s one thing to have it on Etheria inside a base, but another if we moved it to a ship in space,” Micah pointed out. “Sweet Bee would have an easier time decrying it as an attempt to completely control the gate.”

“Well, we do want to control the gate,” Catra reminded them. You couldn’t leave such an asset to others - it would endanger the entire world and damage the war effort.

“Not if it makes us more enemies on Etheria,” Micah told her.

Catra shrugged. As long as they didn’t have the military power to be more than nuisances…

But Adora was nodding in agreement with the king. “Yes.”

Typical.

“We could use magitech to secure the gate in space,” Entrapta suggested.

“I can’t use my spells like that,” Castaspella protested.

“And I think a lot of princesses would be suspicious if we moved the gate to a location where their powers don’t work,” Glimmer added. “No, the gate has to stay on Etheria.”

Catra nodded. A spaceship might be more secure in some ways, but that wasn’t counting magic being used - and that was one of Etheria’s biggest advantages.

You had to play to your strengths if you wanted to win.

*****

“...and are you really sure won’t you reconsider? You do have a significant potential for magic - no inherent powers, as far as we can detect, at least, but you could be a powerful sorcerer, should you get training.”

Jack O’Neill pressed his lips together and tried not to show his annoyance. Castaspella meant well. He knew that much. Or was pretty sure. But she was a sorceress and didn’t seem to get that he wasn’t as crazy about magic as she was. Jack wasn’t going to learn how to cast spells; he was a soldier, not a wizard. Or sorcerer, or whatever they called it here. He was much too old to change careers like that, anyway. Even if he wanted to change tracks. Which he didn’t.

But making her understand that without offending her was becoming a bit of a chore. He tried again, shrugging as he leaned back on the couch in her room. “That may be the case, but I can’t exactly drop out of the war just to start learning cantrips.”

“Cantrips?” She cocked her head to the side, frowning a little as she adjusted her seat across from him.

Damn. He should have never played the game. “Spells. Minor spells.” Daniel would be proud of him for that explanation.

“Ah.” She nodded with a smile. “You know, it’s quite interesting to see that after a thousand years without magic, and, apparently, a significant part of your people trying to eradicate sorcerers, so much of your magical tradition survived.”

He’d have to tell Daniel to check what exactly Etherians were told about Earth. But that could wait. He grinned. “Ah, you know how it is with popular culture. Kids always want the thing they can’t have. Alcohol, magic…”

To his relief, she nodded. If he had to explain the United States’s drinking age again to someone from Etheria - or Europe… But then she frowned. “Although I wonder. Is that why you seem so reluctant to learn magic? Because so many in your society scorn magic and those who practice it?”

Of course not! As if he would let some zealots dictate his actions! He shook his head. “No. But I am too old to change gears like that. And, not trying to sound arrogant, but I think I am much more useful for the war by doing the job I’ve been doing for twenty years instead of spending the war learning magic.” On Etheria, in a flying city, away from his team and Earth.

“Well, while I doubt that anyone can confidently predict how long the war will take, I don’t think you would have to spend the entire time learning magic.” She smiled widely at him, and Jack couldn’t help feeling slightly concerned. “You have such a great potential for our art, no doubt thanks to your First Ones ancestry, I am sure you would not take that long to learn enough spells to become a competent sorcerer!”

He didn’t want to become a sorcerer! And pointy hats looked silly, in uniform or out of it. But saying that would sound silly. And irresponsible. And would end with him explaininjg more of Earth’s pop culture featuring magic. He shook his head again. “But that would still take me out of the war for a year or two. Longer if the

Air Force sends me to teach magic to others afterwards." And they would. Maybe he would get a tour of duty on the frontlines, to get practical experience, but then he'd end up teaching magic to others. That was how things were done in the Air Force, and while it worked well, Jack wasn't looking forward to spending his career doing that instead of leading his team.

And the woman still didn't relent. "Well, I could think of worse teachers than you, to be honest, Jack."

Why did he have to tell her to call him Jack? He should have realised that she'd do it without trouble after spending so much time with Glitter and the others - Etherian royalty didn't act like Earth royals.

"You might not be an experienced sorcerer, but your experience as a soldier certainly would have granted you the wisdom younger students - and older sorceresses as well, in some cases - often desperately need."

"Yeah, I'm not sure I'm a role model for ethics." He grinned, baring his teeth. "I'm a bit too much of a pragmatist." At least according to Etherian standards as embodied by Adora and her friends. "So, anyway, let's focus on fixing my little problem, so no one's going to raise a small army of little kids with my potential but none of my supposed wisdom? I was a pretty dumb kid when I started as a soldier."

"I have trouble imagining that, Jack." She chuckled and folded her hands in her lap.

"Well, easily manipulated instead? I believed a lot of things I should have known better." And wasn't that the truth!

"Ah, yes. Well, you will be welcome at Mystacore whenever you wish, should you reconsider your decision. Now, let's see how you react to a modified sealing spell. Please step into the circle I've prepared - I doubt we'll need the containment, but it's better to be safe than sorry."

And wasn't that reassuring! Still, Jack stepped into the glowing circle full of runes on the floor, trying not to think of ending up as some red mist or stains on the walls, courtesy of a magic mishap.

Or what Carter might be thinking - she hadn't looked happy at all when Castaspella had dragged him off after dinner. He snorted. Maybe staying on Etheria and learning magic in a flying city wouldn't be that bad - it would get him out of explaining things to his second-in-command…

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 31st, 1998 (Earth Time)

"This is an outrage! A blatant attempt to exert control over the entire world! Mark my words: This will not stand! The other kingdoms won't let it!"

When Adora had met Princess Sweet Bee, the other woman had always seemed to be composed and, well, in control of herself and the situation. Granted, she had only met her twice before, once at the Princess Prom, and then only in passing, and yesterday, at the diplomatic meeting with Glimmer and the other members of the Princess Alliance, but even though Sweet Bee had left no doubt that she wasn't happy with the Alliance's policies, she had stayed polite and, well, Catra called it snooty, and Glimmer called it aristocratic.

But the princess wasn't looking very snooty or aristocratic right now. Nor very composed. She was glaring at them like pretty much every instructor had glared at Kyle whenever her friend had screwed up. As if to confirm Adora's thoughts, Sweet Bee slammed the palms of her hand on the conference table and leaned forward, scowling at Glimmer.

Who met her eyes with a glare of her own. "Noted. Is there anything else you wish to address?"

Adora could see how the other princess was clenching her teeth - the jaw muscles twitched noticeably. "The Stargate belongs to all

of Etheria! It is our birthright!”

“Yes,” Glimmer nodded. “But the safety of Etheria takes priority. So civilian use of the Stargate will be restricted until further notice.”

“You don’t have the authority to decide that! You don’t rule or represent Etheria!” Sweet Bee slammed her palms on the table again.

“We represent the Princess Alliance. The ones who saved Etheira before - three times,” Glimmer retorted. “And we’ll do so a fourth time.”

Three times? Adora frowned for a moment.

“Three times?”

“We defeated the Horde, Horde Prime, and stopped the Heart of Etheria from destroying the world,” Glimmer explained.

Sweet Bee scoffed. “You claim you saved the world. But we only have your word for it - and I see your ‘defeated’ enemies amongst your ranks.”

“And the remains of Horde Prime’s flagship in orbit, as well as the stars in the sky,” Catra added. When the princess turned to scowl at her, Adora’s lover flashed her fangs in an insufferable grin.

“You can deny it as much as you want, but it doesn’t change the facts,” Adora spoke up before Catra could get into a spat with the princess. “We are fighting a new war, against an Empire that spans the galaxy, with enemies who can take over people’s bodies to control them. Unrestricted travel through the Stargate is too dangerous.”

“Of course, if you wish to join the Princess Alliance and do your part in defending our world…” Mermista trailed off with a shrug and a smirk that was rather undiplomatic, in Adora’s opinion.

And in Sweet Bee's opinion as well, at least judging by her expression. "You will not get away with this! Etheria is not yours to rule!" she spat. "Many kingdoms are fed up with your arrogance!"

"The same kingdoms that were happy to let the Princess Alliance fight and bleed against the Horde while they sat back?" Glimmer scoffed as well.

"Please!" Perfuma spoke up with a strained smile. "I know you don't like it, and I understand your reasons, but we have good reasons to restrict travel through the gate."

"Just as you have *good reasons* to consort with the Horde?" Sweet Bee scoffed with a sneer.

Perfuma gasped, and Scorpia rose. "Hey, now, that sounds… Well, it sounds like you have a problem with me, not Perfuma."

"I have a problem with the Princess Alliance trying to rule Etheria just as the Horde tried," Sweet Bee retorted.

"But we don't!" Perfuma protested. "We don't want to rule Etheria!"

"Are you seriously comparing us to the Horde?" Glimmer looked angry now - and she was standing as well.

"You're trying to force your policies on the entire world, and you use Horde troops, Horde bases and Horde spaceships." Sweet Bee shook her head.

"Waste not, want not," Catra cut in with a smirk.

Adora frowned at her, and her lover shrugged in return.

"The Princess Alliance isn't the Horde!" Perfuma looked angry. "We've restored the Scorpion Kingdom! We're healing the land! We're not trying to conquer you!"

"You act as if you already did!" Sweet Bee spat. "But we're not your subjects! We're sovereign princesses! And we will fight for our rights!" She turned around, then looked over her shoulder. "You'll hear from us!"

"At the next Princess Prom at the latest!" Catra said before the princess left the room.

Adora sighed. "That could've gone better."

"No, it couldn't have," Glimmer disagreed as she sat down. "She was set on this. The only way we could've avoided this was to give in to her demands."

"They're scared of us," Perfuma said.

"If they were scared, they wouldn't have made such demands," Mermista objected. "They wouldn't have dared to insult us like that if they truly believed we wanted to conquer them."

That sounded… well, kind of logical. "But they still believe we want to rule Etheira," Adora pointed out. "Or dominate it."

"Yes. And that can't be helped unless we dissolved the Princess Alliance," Glimmer said. "As things are, we represent the biggest army on the planet as well as the most powerful princesses."

"They could join us if they want access to the Stargate," Spinnerella said. "But that would force them to fight. And they don't want to fight."

"Too cowardly to join, but not cowardly enough to just accept our policies." Catra shrugged. "Well, that's been dealt with. Let's go check the status of the Stargate?"

As everyone rose, Adora couldn't help feeling that it wasn't as simple as Catra made it sound. But there was nothing else she could do about it right now. Letting everyone use the Stargate was too dangerous.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, December 31st, 1998 (Earth Time)

"Everything reads OK - within expected safety margins. Main processing unit is working at peak efficiency. We're ready for testing!"

Samantha Carter nodded in response to Entrapta's enthusiastic report as she double-checked the results of her own readings. Her numbers confirmed the same thing: they had beaten the odds and replaced the Stargate's missing D.H.D. ahead of schedule - significantly so.

"So, I guess that means we can now go home again? Unless the gate turns the bot into a pretzel, that is?"

"Yes, sir." She suppressed a scowl as she faced the Colonel - she wasn't in the mood for his humour right now. Not because he had spent the evening with Castaspella, of course! She didn't really think that he was having a secret tryst, as Daniel had worded it, with Glimmer's aunt. The Colonel wouldn't do that on a mission. Or at all, she added to herself. But that he wasn't revealing why he was meeting with the woman - whose obvious interest in him, in turn, might not be merely professional or platonic? That didn't sit well with her. Not that she had pressed the issue; you didn't do that to your superior unless it was an emergency. And he would have evaded the question anyway. But she would have expected a bit more trust.

"Ah, good." He looked a little taken aback, then cocked his head to the side and looked at the gate. "I can't wait to get home. Slumming it in a palace just doesn't compare to good old Stargate Command."

"Really?" Entrapta peered at him, sliding her visor up. "You prefer your quarters at your base to the palace guest rooms? Did you tell Glimmer that? Because we could have refurbished your room!"

“Ah…”

“The Colonel was joking,” Sam told her friend. “The guest quarters are lovely and perfectly comfortable.” She glanced at the man in question, who, after a moment, nodded.

“Yeah, sure.”

“Good!” Entrapta made a note on her multitool. Probably in her social data file. “So… ready for the test?

“Will it hurt?” the Colonel quipped.

“The bot isn’t wired to feel pain,” Entrapta told him, completely serious. “And we know from experience that travelling through the Stargate doesn’t normally cause pain anyway. So, it won’t hurt.”

Sam narrowed her eyes at the Colonel, and he winced a little. He really should know better than that by now. “Ah, OK. So, by all means, proceed!”

“OK!” Entrapta turned and called out: “Test-Bot-2! Get ready!”

“Wasn’t the last test-bot a twelve?” the Colonel asked in a low voice.

“That was a spy-bot,” Sam told him. “Spy-Twelve. This is a dedicated testing bot.”

“And what happened to Test-Bot-1?”

“Destructive testing to calibrate the sensors,” Sam told him while she entered the address for Earth.

“Ah.”

The gate started spinning, and the chevrons became locked one after another. The vortex formed as it should as well. “Stable wormhole established,” Sam reported.

“All systems nominal,” Entrapta replied. “Camera feed established. Test-Bot-2, go!”

The bot walked up the ramp, then through the gate - and down the ramp in Stargate Command. Sam checked the sensors. “No deviations from the standard parameters.”

“It works as expected!” Entrapta cheered. “Now we can easily travel back and forth between Earth and Etheria!”

“Nice.” The Colonel nodded and clapped his hands together. ”So, we can go home as soon as the bigwigs return for the official sendoff.”

“‘Bigwigs’?” Entrapta asked.

By the time Daniel had explained - in detail - the term and its origin, Glimmer and the others had arrived.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, Unites States of America, Earth, December 31st, 1998

“The entire leadership of the Princess Alliance is coming to our New Year’s party?” General Hammond repeated himself while he and the other generals were staring at SG-1.

Samantha Carter stood a little bit straighter in response as the Colonel replied: “Yes, sir.”

“And how did that happen?” General Haig asked.

“Well… apparently, they like parties?” The Colonel smiled. “No, really, we were at dinner with them, the party came up, and it turned out everyone assumed that the invitation to Glimmer, Adora and the others included all of them. We didn’t correct them since, well… they were very enthusiastic. They were already talking about dress codes and such.” He shrugged. “It seemed

rude to tell them that they weren't invited. So, in the interest of diplomacy and good relations with our strongest allies, we didn't."

Hammond sighed, closing his eyes for a moment. Sam knew the feeling.

"I see." Haig nodded.

"This is an outrage!" Sidorov, who looked as if he'd wanted to send SG-1 to the next gulag, or at least the arrest cells, bellowed. "You didn't have the authority to invite a diplomatic party!"

"They kind of invited themselves. By accident," the Colonel retorted. "But if you want to revoke the invitations, we can go tell them that."

"That would be a faux pas," General Petit commented with a slight smile. "I am sure we can accommodate a few more guests at our party."

"Yes," Hammond said. "The security measures were already increased since we knew we would be hosting three princesses. A few more shouldn't be an issue."

The Colonel winced. "Ah, yes, speaking of accommodations - we'll also be hosting a magical talking flying horse. So, best not serve horse meat."

For the first time, Sam was treated to the sight of the entire Stargate Command Council blinking.

Explaining Swift Wind took much longer than their original report had taken.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, January 1st, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra snorted as she watched Frosta try not to fidget. The princess was so excited - or nervous - about going to Earth, yet also desperately trying to appear aloof and collected. And failing at that. “It’s just a party,” she muttered to herself, shaking her head.

“Hm?” Adora turned her head to look at her. “What did you say?”

“Nothing,” she said. “Just… well, we’ve been at so many events on Earth, it’s nothing special any more, but for them, it’s something else.” She nodded at the rest of the group waiting in front of the gate.

“They’ve never been on another planet,” Adora said with a smile. Which then turned into a wince. “They’ve never been to Earth.”

Ah. Catra suppressed another snort. Her lover was nervous as well - worried about how the rest of the group would behave on Earth. Especially Swift Wind. “You briefed them. Thoroughly.” It had taken Catra back to their days as Horde cadets, when Adora had tried to cover every little detail and potential problem whenever she ran a briefing.

Adora blushed a little, but her mood didn’t improve. “I’m sure I forgot something, something important…”

And not everyone had been paying attention. But Catra didn’t say that. She shrugged instead. “As long as they behave as if they were at the Princess Prom, things will be fine.”

“I know…” But Adora still worried. Catra could tell.

Before she could think of what else to say to calm down her lover, Swift Wind trotted over to them. “What a glorious day! To think we’ll travel farther than any other horse has ever gone before! To a world full of horses!”

“To a base without any horse in it,” Catra told him.

Swift Wind ignored that. “And I had a thought, Adora!”

“Yes?” Adora tensed a little.

Catra did so as well.

“There are as many horses on Earth as there are people on Etheria. A planet’s worth!”

Oh, no, he couldn’t…

“Yes?” Adora hadn’t caught up yet.

“So, what about giving them a planet of their own? Where they can live free? Except for those who depend on humans, but there could be some humans there taking care of them. But imagine: a world full of horses, for horses!”

Adora blinked. “Uh… a colony of horses?”

“Yes!” Swift Wind nodded enthusiastically.

“Ah… I don’t think we have the logistics and resources to handle such a colony.” Adora smiled weakly. “I’m sorry.”

“Oh.” Swift Wind looked crestfallen.

“And if we give the horses a colony,” Catra managed to say without scoffing at the absurdity of it, “then everyone else will want one as well. Not to mention that we’d have to find a planet first where horses could live.”

“And the, uh, ecological balance might be a problem,” Adora added. “You’d have to ask Perfuma about that, but just moving lots of horses to a new planet is not easy. And on Earth, some horses starved when they escaped into the wilderness for lack of food.”

“Oh.” Swift Wind frowned again. “You’re right. It would have to be a planet full of grass-covered hills and plains.” He nodded. “I’ll ask her about that.” He turned around and trotted over to the other princess.

Catra smirked as she gleaned at her lover. “Nice dodge.”

“It’s the truth,” Adora shot back.

“And now Perfuma has to explain things to Swift Wind.” Catra watched, her ears twitching, as the horse approached the princess, who was fiddling with Scorpia’s dress.

“It’s not his fault,” Adora said. “He didn’t get an education when I, ah, changed him. So, he had to learn things by himself.”

Ah. Catra hadn’t thought of that. “And where did he learn?”

“In Bright Moon. They have the facilities, but…” Adora shrugged. “It’s a very spotty education so far.”

“Ah.” That explained a few things. But it didn’t make things any easier. She turned her attention - and her ears - back to Perfuma’s explanation.

“...and so I can’t just make grass grow - sooner or later, there will be too many horses for the planet’s capacity, and then they will start starving until there is a balance. But it’s a dynamic balance, not a static one. As the numbers of horses fluctuate, so does the amount of grass available since they influence each other, and…”

Swift Wind didn’t like what he was hearing. That was obvious.

“Yeah, nature’s brutal,” Catra mumbled as she tuned the lecture out.

“What did you say?” Adora asked again.

But before Catra could explain, Entrapta spoke up. “Alright! Everyone, get ready - and stay in the marked area, don’t get closer to the gate - we’re about to dial Earth!”

“Finally!” she exclaimed with a grin. “I’ve been waiting for this all day!”

“You were napping all day,” Glimmer commented with a snort while they watched the gate spin.

“I’m a soldier; I learned to sleep whenever I can,” Catra retorted with a smirk.

“All day?”

“What can I say? I’m an overachiever.”

They laughed as the wormhole stabilised and the gate to Earth opened.

“Time to celebrate a new beginning!” Perfuma announced, setting a foot on the gate with Scorpia.

Everyone cheered.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, Unites States of America, Earth, January 1st, 1999

“...and these are Perfuma, Princess of Plumeria, and Princess Scorpia of the Scorpion Kingdom.”

Jack O’Neill had to suppress the urge to add ‘she’s the one who throws tanks for fun’ to Glimmer’s introduction. It didn’t seem necessary, anyway - he could see how the generals were eyeing the smiling woman. Except for Haig, who didn’t seem to be fazed at all, all of them, even Hammond, looked at least a little wary when they greeted her. Although that might be because Scorpia, with her pincers and her stinger, poised above her head, looked the most alien of all the princesses. Of course, Catra had fur, cat ears and a tail as well, but her claws were usually hidden, and she didn’t look as if she could throw a tank around.

“Thank you for inviting us!”

On the other hand, Catra also never looked as happy as Scorpia - the princess was beaming at everyone when she wasn't looking around the gate area like a tourist. And she was a striking sight, in a black dress that fit her like a glove and wouldn't have looked out of place on a catwalk in Paris.

"Yes!" Perfuma, her arm hooked into Scorpia's, wearing a light green dress that complimented Scorpia's somehow, nodded with a smile as wide as her… consort's? Wife's? "It's an honour to be able to attend your celebration! We're looking forward to taking part in such an important event."

That was a bit too much praise for a New Year's office party - especially one held in a military base for the soldiers stuck on duty over the holidays. Jack glanced at Glimmer, who kept smiling politely, then at Adora. The princess was wincing a little, and next to her, Catra was grinning. So, probably a misunderstanding that Adora felt guilty for and Catra found funny. Business as usual, then.

Jack stopped grinning, though, when he noticed that Hammond was glancing at him with a slight frown. That wasn't his fault! He'd had more important things to do than explaining the finer point of an office party to the Etherians! If anyone, it should have been Daniel!

But Glimmer was already moving to introduce the next couple. "Mermista, Princess of Salineas, and Sea Hawk."

Hammond didn't say 'the Smuggler' in return, but Jack was sure - pretty sure - that he was thinking it.

"It's a great adventure!" the man in question, dressed quite flamboyantly, exclaimed.

"Ugh. Behave," Mermista, who apparently had also gone to great effort in picking her pearl-studded dress, added with a scowl before smiling at the generals. "Thank you for having us. I'll make sure he won't set fire to anything."

“I would never! We’re underground, after all!”

Sea Hawk’s comment wasn’t as reassuring as the man probably thought. Jack decided to impress upon Siler that they should double-check the smoke detectors.

“Princess Frosta of the Kingdom of Snows.”

“Greetings.” The teenage princess nodded with such seriousness, it made her look even younger than she was. At least in Jack’s opinion.

But the girl was the sovereign leader of one of the largest kingdoms of Etheria. And could freeze you in a block of ice with a thought. And the generals greeted her with the utmost courtesy. Well, except for Sidorov, who went through the motions and said the words but couldn’t quite keep the sneer off his face. If the man kept this up, then the formal diplomatic event scheduled to follow the party would have some grievances to deal with. And they would blame Jack for it; he was sure. Even though it hadn’t been his idea to let Stargate Command handle the party even after the entire Princess Alliance announced their intention to attend.

“Princess Netossa and Princess Spinnerella of the Alliance.”

Not ruling princesses, in other words. Still the Etherian version of generals. But the government - governments, actually - preferred to err on the side of caution and just treated all of them as sovereigns. At least etiquette didn’t require you to bow. That would have felt wrong - you didn’t bow to anyone in your own home. At least in Jack’s opinion.

“King Micah of Bright Moon. My father. And Castaspella of Mystacore, my aunt.”

Jack kept smiling and reminded himself that the sorceress was helping him - had helped him already. Even though she made no secret of her opinion that Jack should become a sorcerer himself.

Under her tutelage. In a magical flying city. But she wasn't pushy. Well, not as pushy as, say, Anise.

And Micah and her were old enough to be taken seriously even by Sidorov, which facilitated matters.

"Swift Wind."

And there was Jack's biggest problem.

"Faithful mount of She-Ra, linked by a sacred bond, and liberator of horses everywhere!" the horse boasted as he stepped forward, wings flaring - and sending a few sheets of papers in the back flying. "Greetings, people of Earth!"

Someone must have shown him cheesy science-fiction movies! Jack was sure of it. He kept his thoughts off his face, though.

Unlike the rest of the people in the room, who were more or less openly staring at the magical talking flying unicorn.

Except for Haig. The damn limey merely nodded as if Swift Wind was a normal guest.

Of course, as a British officer, he probably was used to dealing with eccentric blue bloods.

Well, Jack had a feeling that even the general's composure would be tested before the party was over. It would be funny if Jack wasn't going to be held responsible for it.

Even if it wasn't his fault at all!

*****

The New Year's Party

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, Unites States of America, Earth, January 1st, 1999

Adora was a little nervous as she approached the mess hall. The Stargate Command New Year's Party - that was the official title, as a poster next to the door announced - wasn't an Earth version of the Princess Prom. If her friends expected a ball and grand buffet, they would be disappointed. Sure, she had told them that it was a party for the soldiers stuck on the base over the holidays. Several times, in fact. But the way the others were beaming, looking at everything along the way, she feared that they might not have really understood what that meant. They were princesses, after all. And they had always been princesses. Except for Sea Hawk and Swift Wind, and, technically, Micah and Castaspella. OK, most of them were princesses. But they were used to the parties thrown by and for princesses. Not parties thrown by and for common soldiers in an army of millions.

Adora couldn't help thinking that the Stargate Command New Year's Party would be more like what parties they had thrown as cadets in the Horde than the Princess Prom or the victory celebrations of the Alliance after Horde Prime's defeat.

"Remember, this is a military base," she said as they stepped through the door, following Jack and the others. "They can't…" She blinked. The mess hall looked very different - if she hadn't been here before, and seen the hallway outside, she would have thought she had entered the wrong room.

Catra whistled. "They've pulled out all the stops." She sniffed the air. "Tuna salad. Smoked salmon. Fried fish. The good stuff."

"Look at that buffet!"

"Oh, look at the stage!"

“Look at the sound system! Emily, scan it!”

“Oh! And so many different uniforms! I thought this was all the same army, like the Horde!”

“Air Force, mostly - and not any more,” Adora corrected Scorpia. “Soldiers from five countries are now guarding the gate.”

“Oh.”

“And they’ve got several different branches in each army,” Bow added. “With different uniforms. Although I thought it was a more casual affair. Those are dress uniforms.”

Indeed. Adora frowned - she was sure that the dress code in the invitation hadn’t mentioned dress uniforms. On the other hand, maybe that was the standard for such events, and so they hadn’t mentioned it?

“Well, you said this was a small party, but this doesn’t look small,” Perfuma said. “Not at all.”

“Beats Force Captain parties for sure.” Scorpia nodded. “We usually had no decorations and mostly pilfered food and drinks.”

Indeed. It was grander than Adora had expected. It looked more like a formal state dinner, with all the white tablecloth covering up the… were those new tables? Definitely new chairs.

“I think that’s our fault,” Glimmer said.

“Our fault?” Micah cocked his head to the side.

“When they heard that all of us would attend, they probably went over their plans for the whole thing,” Glimmer explained.

“Yep,” Jack chimed in with a grin. “The funds for the party were mysteriously but generously increased this week. This isn’t how our New Year’s party usually looks like.”

“I thought so,” Catra said with a matching grin.

“Me too,” Adora added.

“You did all of this in a few days?” Frosta sounded impressed. Well, she had organised the last Princess Prom, so she would know better what went into such events than Adora.

“Yep. The United States have a long tradition of doing miracles when it comes to logistics.” Jack snorted. “Of course, I can’t take all credit since I spent most of the last week on Etheria.”

“What a coincidence,” Catra commented.

“I know - but duty comes first.”

Once more, their grins matched. It was… kind of weird, in Adora’s opinion.

“Colonel O’Neill - we shouldn’t leave our guests standing,” General Haig said, nodding at the table.

“Right, right! This way, please!” Jack gestured to the table with a flourish, as if they hadn’t seen it from the entrance. “We’ve left one spot free for Swift Wind.”

Indeed, there was one chair missing - and there was open space behind it, more than enough for him to stand there comfortably.

“Oh, nice!” Swift Wind beamed.

“We try.” Jack smiled.

Unfortunately, the route Swift Wind took wasn’t quite as roomy, and Jack’s grin vanished when Swift Wind’s wings almost pushed two people out of their chairs. “Ah. We asked an expert on horses. We probably should have asked an expert on pegasuses.”

“You have more like Swift Wind on Earth?” Perfuma asked. “I thought you didn’t have any magic for a thousand years…”

“They’re talking about fiction,” Glimmer told her. “Imaginary creatures.”

“Ah.”

“I am sorry,” Swift Wind said as he settled at his spot.

“It’s OK,” Jack told him.

“Although, it is intriguing,” Castaspella said. “You closely match creatures of legend and myth on Earth. Perhaps those creatures lived on Earth during the time it had magic.” She smiled. “It bears investigating.”

“But after the party, I think,” Jack said with a slightly strained-looking smile, gesturing again at the table.

“Oh, yes. We can discuss this afterwards - do you have quarters here?” Castaspella asked.

Jack’s smile grew more strained, Adora noticed, as General Hammond’s eyebrows rose.

And Catra was grinning again.

But all things considered, the party was off to a good start.

*****

Samantha Carter was late for the New Year’s party. It wasn’t her fault - well, not really. That experiment had run a bit longer than expected, and cleaning up after it, as well as sorting the data, had taken a bit longer as well. If she hadn’t been roped - ordered - into helping with the party, she would have finished in time, of course. But between the mission to Etheria and the scramble to turn a casual party for soldiers into as close one could get to a state dinner without turning it into a state dinner, there simply hadn’t been any time.

Of course, usually, that wouldn't be much of an issue - she had been late to the last two New Year's parties as well. As long as she arrived in time to grab something to eat from the chow line - the buffet, she corrected herself - no one made much of a fuss. Although the Colonel would probably have threatened to drag her out of her lab if he hadn't been swamped with the preparations himself, she added to herself with a smile.

Things were different this time, of course, but she was only late by about fifteen minutes. And she had a good excuse. Not even Sidorov could complain about her work taking precedence. Her presence wasn't needed amongst the welcoming party, anyway - the Colonel could handle that perfectly fine, no matter what he claimed. Especially since he had Daniel with him - her friend had no excuse not to attend since his work didn't rely on experiments; books could be put aside without ruining an expensive set of components.

She approached the door, nodding at the two guards outside - marines had drawn the short straw, it seemed; security had been increased as a response to the additional guests - and opened the door.

And blinked. She had known that the decorations would be more extensive than usual, but… This was a bit excessive. No, not a bit - a lot. She couldn't even see the walls behind all the plants, and only the lighting fixtures in the ceiling were not covered by foliage and flowers, either. Flowers that looked as if the decorator had raided an exotic greenhouse. Well, Perfuma loved it - she was beaming as she pointed at a particularly colourful flower dangling overhead.

Sam managed to greet her friends without being too distracted, but as soon as she was seated next to the Colonel, she leaned over and said in a low voice: "I don't remember seeing that in the plans."

"Yep." The Colonel grinned. "It seems no one told General Petit that you should not comment about the challenge of decorating a

mess hall on short notice when a magical princess with control over plants can overhear it and wants to be helpful."

"Ah." That explained it. And why the French General was so focused on his discussion with King Micah and ignoring the glares from his fellow officers. And why Catra was smirking.

Well, no harm done - Sam trusted Perfuma's power; she didn't doubt that the plants would hold up nicely. Probably better than the original decorations since those had been thrown together quite hastily - Sam had been there when the changes had been made.

She blinked. Maybe she should ask Perfuma to ensure that the plants would come off without too much effort. Or wilted in the morning, or whatever. The princess might be easily capable of creating plants that thrived underground and could take root in concrete. Or at least adhere to it. And if those were genetically - magically - altered plants based on alien flora, they might have just violated a few laws…

"Cleaning up afterwards might be a bit of a challenge," she commented as she filled her glass.

The Colonel frowned for a moment. Then his eyes widened, and his lips moved as he muttered something under his breath that Sam was sure was a curse.

Well, that wasn't her problem. And she wouldn't mind a greener mess hall, either - Stargate Command was moving anyway.

*****

"...and don't worry, the plants won't require too much care - a bit of watering and the artificial light will be enough to sustain them as long as you want to keep them going since I changed the foliage so they can extract nitrogen from the air to serve as fertiliser."

Catra smirked as she listened to Perfuma's enthusiastic explanation to the not-quite-so-enthusiastic General Hammond.

"Catra!" Adora hissed.

"Hm?"

"It's not funny!"

"Yes, it is," Catra disagreed. And it was. The general was obviously trying to find a way to politely tell the princess that they didn't want permanent flowers in the mess hall without making her feel bad for misunderstanding their intentions. And probably without Perfuma changing the flowers into vegetables or something.

"That is very impressive," he said. "Although we were not planning to have the plants take root here."

Perfuma beamed at him. "Oh, don't worry about that! I changed the plants so their roots don't bury into the ground - or the walls and ceiling here - but simply adhere to the surfaces. They'll also filter out some of the pollutants in the air and improve the microclimate in the room, so your air filters should be under less stress."

"Fascinating." Haig leaned over. "Could this replace conventional air conditioning in underground bases? Combined with the Tok'ra tunnelling technology, this could provide forward bases with greater autarchy."

"Oh, I would have to modify and optimise the plants for that, and you'd need a pretty large area covered - depending on how many people are in the bunker, of course; the fewer you have, the fewer plants you need to provide enough oxygen."

Catra didn't miss the subtle frown Hammond sent at the other general and grinned again. "I think that would require further research," he said. "We can't really use untested technology in our bases."

“Oh, we can test it easily - this room can serve as a testing site!” Perfuma turned her head and called out to Entrapta. “Entrapta! Can you test how well the plants here filter and replace the air? So we can use them in bases?”

“Sure thing!” Entrpata nodded. “I’ll set up some sensors to collect data!”

Hammond’s frown wasn’t subtle at all any more. “I think such a decision needs to be discussed amongst the command council.”

Haig raised his eyebrows. “We are already using this technology, so to speak, so it would behove us to thoroughly test it as the opportunity presents itself.”

“And Perfuma can adjust the plants as you wish,” Scorpia chimed in, beaming at her lover. “If you want different colours for daily use, for example.”

“Or adaptive colouration.” Perfuma nodded. “If you wish to make the plants more discreet. I wouldn’t think it’s necessary - quite the contrary; plants add so much character and comfort to a bunker - but I am a bit biased.”

“Oh, yes! The Fright Zone has become so much more appealing and nicer thanks to all the plants covering the buildings! And that’s all your work!”

And more beaming followed. Hammond glanced at O’Neill for some reason, but the other man was still talking with Castaspella. And Haig nodded.

“It seems that the plants are going to stay,” Catra commented as she stood. “I’m going to grab another plate. Want some as well?”

“Uh…” Adora joined her. “Yes.”

As they walked over to the buffet, Catra overheard Swift Wind talking to Dr Fraiser.

"...but why would I have problems with people eating cows or pigs? They're nasty! Have you ever tried to reason with a bull? Besides, you don't have any problem eating them either, right?"

"Ah, no, of course not." Fraiser grimaced and tried to hide it by taking another sip from her glass.

Catra smiled. Good food, good entertainment and good friends. This was going to be a great party!

*****

This was a disaster! Jack O'Neill already knew it. And he was going to get the blame for it, even though it wasn't his fault! The mess hall had been transformed into an indoor jungle - at least the walls and the ceiling; the floor seemed to be unchanged so far, but he expected some plants sprouting up in a corner near the buffet as soon as someone mentioned the lack of fresh fruits in the regular menu where Perfuma could overhear it.

And he had thought that Entrapta was the one princess to be watched lest she started some unauthorised alterations to the base or unleashed some replicating bots or grey goo! If only he had known…

And it wasn't as if he could've stopped Perfuma anyway - as a colonel, he couldn't just go over the heads of the generals in charge of Stargate Command. At least not when they were right there. That simply wasn't done - short of a life-and-death situation, of course. But an alien princess enthusiastically redecorating the room after misunderstanding Petit's comment wasn't such an emergency. Not even when the entire command council was just sitting there and staring as the room turned into what could have passed for a jungle set of an old tv show. At least Haig seemed to be more intrigued than shocked by the whole thing, but that could just be that British stiff upper lip thing. Jack somehow doubted that the limey was too fond of his base turning into a jungle.

And speaking of jungle… He glanced at the ceiling, squinting a bit. The last thing he wanted was some alien plant dropping pollen into his food or something.

“Don’t worry. Perfuma is an expert with perfect control over her creations. Only cactuses gave her some trouble, but she has overcome that for the most part, I believe.” Castaspella smiled at him.

Jack forced himself to smile. “Yeah, you know - trust but verify. Instincts.”

“Of course, if you are truly worried, I could cast a spell to protect our food, although it might be seen as a slight against Perfuma’s competence.”

“No, no, that’s OK.” Jack wasn’t really worried about inhaling or eating weird alien pollen - Perfuma didn’t strike him as the type who was overconfident or reckless. And he didn’t really want Castaspella doing magic right now, either. Her attempts to show him how useful magic could be were subtle, but he hadn’t missed how she had never failed to offer a magical solution to the smallest problem ever since he declined her offer to become a student at Etheria’s flying magic school.

As if a bit of convenience would be enough to go back to school - and leave his team in the middle of a war. And learn magic.

“Oh, I like this dessert.”

“Yeah, it’s not blue jello, but apple pie is an American classic.” Jack smiled. It was actually far better than the pies they usually served in the Air Force - they had ordered them from a bakery in Colorado Springs. And paid a premium for the rush order.

“I didn’t see blue jello at the dessert buffet, though, I think,” Castaspella added with a slight frown.

“That’s because blue jello is not sophisticated enough for such a swanky event,” Jack told her.

Daniel, sitting across from him next to Castaspella, sighed. “That’s not quite correct. Blue jello is… well, mass-produced.”

“And tasty!” Jack cut in.

“And full of additives of questionable quality,” Daniel continued.

“That’s what makes it so good!”

Castaspella snorted at that.

“We can sneak you a cup later,” Jack told her. “I’ve got a key to the kitchen.”

“Jack!” Daniel gasped.

“What?” Jack pouted at him. “I’ve got a key for every door here. Legitimately.”

“That’s not what I meant!”

“I think I would like to taste this blue jello, if only to compare it to your other fare.”

“Jack! Are you honestly trying to take our guests on a snack raid?” Daniel looked aghast.

Well, Jack had been joking, but now that he thought of it, it seemed like…

“A snack raid? That sounds like an *adventure*!”

…a really dumb idea, Jack finished his thought. How had he missed Sea Hawk passing by their seats, carrying a tray loaded with all the dessert dishes? A tray the man was now holding high as he posed, one boot placed on an empty chair. Attracting the attention of everyone in view. Which included all the generals. And the princesses. And everyone seemed to be frowning at him and Sea Hawk.

“No, we’re not going to raid the kitchen,” Mermista snapped.

“But… Jack said so!” Sea Hawk, still balancing about a week’s worth of dessert on the tray, turned to pout at the princess.

“He was just flirting with Castaspella,” Mermista retorted. “It wasn’t a general invitation. Now come and put the tray down.”

“Ah, of course! That’s different, then!”

Jack blinked as the man winked at him and Castaspella. “That’s not…”

But Sea Hawk was already walking away, humming what sounded like a shanty.

Castaspella was chuckling, and Jack hoped that was because she knew he hadn’t been flirting with her.

He really didn’t need any more rumours about alien women trying to seduce him - or, worse, him trying to seduce them. If Daniel started to call him ‘Kirk’...

At least Carter didn’t seem to have noticed the whole thing - she was still deep in conversation with Entrapta.

*****

Well, things were going better than Adora had expected - feared, actually. Most seemed to like what Perfuma had done to the plant decorations, even though a few seemed worried about it. But General Haig was quite interested in the potential applications of those plants for the war effort. At least as far as Adora could tell - the man was, well, he didn’t seem very emotional. When he smiled, it was a polite smile, and when he didn’t smile, it was a polite non-smile. Something, Jack once had told her, was typical for the English. Stiff upper lip, he had called it. Although it wasn’t a medical condition - she had asked.

Adora wasn’t sure if he was correct, though. What she had seen of the English in their news seemed to contradict it - they had looked like a rather rowdy bunch to her. Especially during protests

and when watching sports. Some sports, at least. But then, Britain had more people than Etheria, so it should be obvious that they would be at least as diverse as the Etherians. Probably - she wasn't an expert on that stuff, and both Bow and Daniel were currently busy talking with others, so it would be rude to interrupt them. Especially since they seemed to be having fun.

Like Catra, who was on her third trip to the dessert buffet. "They should be serving that stuff every day," she said as she retook her seat.

Adora snatched a muffin - blueberry - from the plate and nodded. "Yes."

"So, why don't you?" Catra asked General Hammond between devouring two such muffins herself.

Adora refrained from frowning. Unlike on other occasions, Catra wasn't intentionally rude, simply caught up by how good the dessert was.

"We don't have the budget for it," General Hammond replied. "And if we had the budget, we probably wouldn't find enough suppliers for everyone."

"Oh." Well, it wasn't too bad - compared to the Horde rations, even the regular food Jack kept grumbling about was good. But Bright Moon's food was better, even in the field.

"You should reevaluate your priorities," Catra said with a smirk. "Some Horde soldiers deserted for better food."

"Really?" That was the first time Adora had heard this. She knew - although she had only been told after the war - that there had been a thriving trade in Alliance food in the Horde, but for people to desert for it…

"Oh, yes. Glimmer and Bow told me about your reaction to decent food." Catra snorted.

Adora blushed as she remembered that day. “That was after I had deserted already!”

“Ah.” General Hammond chuckled.

And that had been the day that Thaymor had been attacked. By Catra. Adora felt her smile slip.

Catra shrugged. “Anyway, we’ll make sure we’ll get our food from our own sources, then.”

“That might be bad for morale,” General Hammond pointed out. “If people in the same unit eat different food, that could breed resentment.”

“Really?” Adora frowned. Both the Horde and the Alliance had different food for the leaders than for the soldiers.

“Don’t you have officer’s clubs as well in your army?” Catra asked.

Hammond shook his head. “That’s not the same. In the field, both enlisted and officers eat the same food. At the base, officers might have the opportunity to go to restaurants - they receive money to buy their food.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded. That was different - although not quite as different as the general claimed it was, at least as she understood things.

“Doesn’t sound that equal to me,” Catra commented. “Though it depends on how long you spend in the field. And how things work out on the ships. I don’t think we’ll have restaurants on the ships.”

Adora didn’t think so either. Adapting a frigate to transport human troops in sizeable numbers was already complicated. The soldiers expected more comfortable quarters than what the clones and bots had used under Horde Prime. And that meant that, unless some structural changes were made, the troop complement of a frigate would be on the short side. Which meant they would need more frigates for transport - and while they would still be able to

fight, you generally were not supposed to use transport ships on the frontlines. If the troops expected restaurants and clubs in a frigate, then that would reduce the transport capacity even more…

"I don't think so either," General Hammond said. "Though, even if it is playing to the worst stereotype about the Air Force, I expect our field bases will be quite comfortable."

"Oh, definitely!" Adora smiled. "With the Tok'ra's technology, we'll be able to build and expand a base quickly and easily. And if Perfuma and General Haig's plans work out, it will be even easier. Fresh produce inside the base, for example!"

"We should put in some fish tanks, too," Catra added. "Like in restaurants."

"I don't know if we could put in enough such tanks to feed a base," General Hammond replied politely.

"Well, we could install clone pods for fish." Catra grinned, and Adora wasn't sure if her lover was serious. Although…

"Yes. I think Entrapta mentioned cloned meat as a way to make supplying troops easier. With Perfuma's help, we could probably produce both vegetables and meat on any planet - or in a ship," Adora explained.

"I see. But would that be safe?"

"Probably safer than using animals and plants from wherever," Catra told him. "You'll know exactly where the cloned animals have been and what they have eaten."

"We have strict standards for our food production," General Hammond said.

"Yeah, but whether or not they're strict enough seems a bit controversial." Catra shrugged again. "And we could pick the best animals for cloning - the costs are the same per animal, anyway."

“I see.” Hammond nodded. “Of course, that would be a boon for the war effort, though it might raise some concern amongst the civilian population.”

“Really?” Adora frowned. “Because they don’t trust the technology?” She had seen a rather passionate debate about genetically modified food once, she remembered.

“There is that, But that technology could also render our entire agricultural sector obsolete,” he said.

“Oh.” Adora wasn’t an expert on Earth, but she knew enough to tell that this would probably cause trouble.

“Yeah.” Catra nodded. “But it’ll greatly simplify logistics. And logistics win wars.”

“Yes. But at what cost? If we lose the support of the people, we’ll lose the war.” Hammond shrugged. “And the agricultural lobby has a great deal of influence in Washington - and in Brussels.”

That was the capital of the European Union. If you could call it a capital since the Union wasn’t a country but more of an alliance, as Adora understood it. Still, with so many of those countries in the Alliance, using cloned meat for food might be more of a problem than Adora had thought.

“Well, then we can keep the technology to ourselves,” Catra suggested.

General Hammond winced a little. “A lot of our agricultural businesses are also expecting contracts to supply the armed forces.”

“It sounds like those businesses have more power on Earth than princesses have on Etheria,” Catra commented.

Adora nodded in agreement.

“It’s not quite the same, I would say, but the government has to balance the military needs with those of the economy.” General Hammond inclined his head.

Catra snorted. “Whatever it is, it’s a problem if it means we’ll have to eat bad food in the field!”

“The regular food is not that bad,” Adora pointed out. “It’s much better than Horde rations.”

“That’s a very low bar,” Catra retorted. “Anyway…” She trailed off and frowned. “I think Sidorov made a mistake. Frosta looks like she’s about to hit him with an ice gauntlet.”

Adora turned her head. Oh, no - Frosta did look angry. Not angry enough to actually start a fight, though. Or so Adora hoped. But… “What is he saying?”

Catra cocked her head. “Oh… he’s talking about Russia. And the North Pole.”

That sounded safe, actually.

“But he’s sounding very arrogant - patronising,” Catra went on. “He could only make things worse if he blew up her palace at her ball.”

Adora winced. “We have to stop that. We…”

A gust of wind blew most of the napkins on the table across the room - Swift Wind had flared his wings, this time knocking a man out of his seat. “Sorry!” he said before turning to look at one of the young soldiers who had wandered over to talk to him during dessert. “See? They fold out like that!”

“And you can fly with them?” the woman asked. “With a rider?”

“Of course! I can show you!”

Adora gasped. “Not indoors!”

Swift Wind turned his head. “Of course not, Adora! You’d hit your head on the ceiling here. But we could step outside for a moment, and I could show them how we can fly.”

The soldiers - many of the women, Adora noticed - nodded eagerly.

“Ah…” Adora glanced at Frosta, whose hands had disappeared under the table. That wasn’t a good sign. But maybe…

“Don’t look at me,” Catra told her with a snort. “The kid won’t listen to me, and Sidorov won’t either.”

“Adora, come! Just a short flight!”

“You could take one of us up!”

“Or all of us!”

“Ah, I am sorry, but I am Adora’s faithful steed, ladies.”

“And this is a party, not a rodeo,” Jack stepped in. “So, please don’t bother our guests about giving you rides, OK?”

“Yes, sir!” Half of them saluted. The rest pouted. But it seemed they had one crisis averted. That still left Frosta to, ah, calm down. And… what was Entrapta doing there at the sound system?

*****

Samantha Carter caught the flying napkin before it hit Entrapta in the face, then glanced at the culprit. Just to check that it wasn’t anything serious; this was a party, not a mission, and she was here to enjoy herself.

And it didn’t seem to be anything serious. Swift Wind was flaring his wings, probably to impress what could only be called a bunch of fans. And the Colonel was there. Nothing to be concerned about, then. Sam could focus with Entrapta on her current project.

"...and with that, we should be able to increase the output by three hundred per cent. Now we need to sync that with the holoprojectors. Hm. Maybe… Like this?" Entrapta pointed at the interface of the sound system.

Sam checked the connection while she quickly ran through the specs in her head. "Yes, I think that should work - provided that the emulator can handle the data and extrapolate a 3D projection from the television signal."

"Oh, it should! I've run months of broadcasting data through it, with all the multiple angles, and the neural matrix's error rate has steadily gone down. And it's just for fun, so some mistakes are acceptable, right?"

"Yes." Probably - there might be the matter of copyrighted material, but adapting a 3D projector could be called transformative, couldn't it? Not that there was a chance that a lawsuit would go anywhere, anyway - or be launched at all; people wouldn't risk getting excluded from using the technology for their own business. Provided it worked, of course.

Which it should - Sam had gone through Entrapta's data between the main course and dessert, and it was a really simple project; all the crucial work had been done already, and now it was just about adapting the different machines.

"Good! Now… power supply."

"There's an outlet there."

"Right! Hordak can plug in the converter once he's back from the shuttle."

A sudden commotion - chairs being pushed back, people getting up in a hurry - made Sam turn around. Sidorov was at the centre of it, with Hammond next to him, and Frosta marching away from… an ice sculpture of a monster, a monstrous walrus, it looked like, taking up a big part of the table in front of the Russian? Including his plate?

Well, it wasn't her problem, and General Hammond was already handling it. Although Sam still took a few readings, just to have some data on magically created ice and how it reacted to the environment. That might be useful for a number of projects.

"Oh, Frosta looks mad!" Entrapta commented as the young princess stomped out of the room. "I wonder what he said to her."

"I don't know," Sam replied. "It could have been anything."

"It was probably a misunderstanding. The general has a granddaughter her age."

Sam suppressed a frown as she turned her head. Lenkova had joined her and Entrapta without Sam noticing her approaching them. Granted, according to the Colonel, the Russian was a spy, but still - Sam wasn't used to being blindsided like that.

"Oh?" Entrapta smiled at the other woman. "You think he mistook her for his granddaughter?"

Lenkova blinked, then grinned, if a bit weakly. "In a manner of speaking, da. He tends to be a bit protective of children, and the princess struck me as… not appreciating that."

Sam pressed her lips together. She didn't know Frosta very well, but from what she had seen and heard, the girl did have a chip on her shoulder about being treated as a child. Even though she was a teenager.

"Ah!" Entrapta nodded. "Yes, Frosta likes to fight and protect others." She cocked her head to the side. "Oh, Micah is going after her. I think."

Indeed, the king was leaving the room as well.

"Is that a good thing?" Lenkova asked.

"Yes. I think." Entrapta shrugged, then smiled at the Russian. "So, are you interested in music?"

“Music?” Lenkova raised her eyebrows but otherwise didn’t react to the abrupt change of subject.

“I noticed that we don’t have a live band here, so Sam and I decided to get the next best thing: A holographic projection of a band! Any band! You just insert the data from a video, and the projector takes it and turns it into a projection! Of the band.”

“That sounds… difficult.”

“Oh, it’s not too difficult. In theory - we’re testing the theory now!”

Lenkova glanced at Sam. “I see.”

Sam smiled, although she couldn’t help showing her teeth. “It’s perfectly safe.”

“I didn’t doubt that.” Lenkova didn’t quite snap at her, but the Russian pressed her lips together for a second after her small outburst. “I just wondered why you’re doing it now and not, ah, earlier.”

“We didn’t think of it before now,” Entrapta explained. “And we were busy. And it’s fun, and you’re supposed to have fun at a party.”

“Ah.” Lenkova seemed to accept that.

“Here is the converter.” Hordak had returned, handing the piece of technology over, then cocked his head sideways as he looked at Lenkova. “Are you here to help?”

“What? No. I was just curious,” she replied.

Hordak nodded but kept looking at her, Sam noticed. “About the project?”

“Yes.”

“Well, now you know! Do you have a favourite musician?” Entrapta asked as she knelt down, her hair fanning out as it grabbed cables and started plugging them in.

“Bogdan Titomir,” Lenkova said. “Although I doubt that you have videos of him.”

“Emily, check our data!” Entrapta ordered.

The bot beeped in response, and Sam went back to checking the interface when the Colonel approached them.

“What are you doing, Carter?” He looked a bit harried, she noticed.

“We’re installing a holoprojector,” Entrapta explained without looking up from where she was now halfway under the main amp, which was held up by her hair.

“And I asked if they had videos of Bogdan Titomir,” Lenkova added.

“Can’t say I know the man,” the Colonel said, glancing at her. “And how are you liking the party so far, Lieutenant?”

“It’s… interesting. But a bit tame,” she replied.

“Tame?” The Colonel’s eyebrows rose.

Sam felt a bit surprised herself. They had magical princesses and an alicorn here, the ceiling and walls were covered by magical plants trying to turn the scene into a jungle, and Lenkova called it tame?

“In Russia, everyone would be drunk by now.” The woman smiled a bit ruefully, in Sam’s opinion.

“Ah, yes. No drunks here,” the Colonel said. “Which is a good thing, of course - imagine trying to tell Frosta she couldn’t get a

drink while everyone else was drinking." He looked at Sidorov, who was now seated again and scowling at General Hammond.

"Why not serve her a drink, then?" Lenkova asked.

"Because drunk teenagers with magic are as bad as drunk teenagers with weapons," the Colonel said, clenching his teeth for a moment. Then he took a deep breath and looked at the ceiling. "Imagine if Perfuma were drunk doing this!"

"Ah." Lenkova nodded as if that hadn't been obvious. Then she glanced at Castaspella, who was still sitting at the table. Good. "Is that what you talked about with the witch?"

"Sorceress," the Colonel corrected her. "Witches are different - it's a touchy thing for them or something."

"Ah." Lenkova smiled as if that had answered her question - which it had, of course.

"Yes." Entrapta slid out from under the amplifier. "All set here!"

Sam looked at her readouts. "Same here."

"Good! Then we can now test it!"

"Test what exactly?" the Colonel asked.

"I told you - a holoprojector!" Entrapta smiled. "Switch it on, Hordak - wait, we need to pick a video first!"

Emily beeped.

"You found one? Great! Science buddy, hit it!"

A moment later, the machinery they had spent half an hour setting up sprang to life, and a life-sized hologram of a singer appeared on the small stage set up in the room.

Not just a singer, a rapper, Sam realised as the man opened his mouth.

“You made this for a Russian Rapper?” The Colonel sounded both amused and put off.

“Ukrainian, actually,” Lenkova corrected him. “At least these days.”

“And they like it!” Entrapta beamed.

Indeed, people were clapping and cheering. Of course, seeing a hologram would be a novelty, and there were a significant number of Russian soldiers present who recognised the singer, but she wasn’t wrong.

Sam smiled at the Colonel.

Of course, he had to have the last word: “Well, as long as you don’t show a polka band…”

Unfortunately, Entrapta overheard him. “What’s polka?”

But clearing up that wasn’t Sam’s job either. She was here to have fun, as the Colonel had told her three times today already.

And she was having fun.

Until she noticed the officer in charge of the night shift entering the hall - and heading straight towards the table with the generals. Something must have come up.

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The Intervention Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, Unites States of America, Earth, January 1st, 1999

Catra perked up as she noticed the officer approaching the generals. Not that it took a particularly sharp eye to catch it - the man wasn't wearing a dress uniform, so he stood out amongst the party's guests. O'Neill had noticed him as well and was already heading back to the general's table.

But it took damn good ears to listen in at that distance, with Entrapta's holo-singer going off in the background and everyone talking - and Catra had the best ears in the room. She turned them in Hammond's direction just in time to catch the gist of the message.

"...didn't open the iris, but we accepted the radio call from the Tok'ra. They claim it's an emergency and want to talk to the Alliance leadership."

Oh.

"I see."

"Let's get up," Catra told Adora as Hammond frowned. "It's for you."

"What?" Adora looked at her.

"Call from the Tok'ra," Catra explained. "For the Alliance leadership." Technically, Stargate Command wasn't part of the Alliance. At least not directly. And the Russians and Chinese certainly weren't part of the Alliance. And Adora was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance.

"Oh. Glimmer!" Adora called out. "We have to take a call!"

"What?" But Glimmer was already on her feet, Bow following her.

And that started a general move towards the doors by everyone from Etheria - and a lot of murmuring and speculation amongst the soldiers from Stargate Command. Which quickly drowned out the singing.

Sometimes, having the best ears in the room wasn't a good thing.

She grabbed a last sandwich on the way out.

*****

"I'm sorry, General, but this is Alliance business - not Stargate Command business."

"What? This is Stargate Command! This is the Stargate!"

"Yes, but only in as much as it's needed for transportation and communication, General."

"We have oversight over all gate activities! This is a matter of security!"

"The majority of the Command Council is present, sir. Therefore, it shouldn't…"

Catra shook her head with a sigh as the door slid close and cut off the angry ranting from Sidorov outside the gate room. "We should take control of the Stargate here as well."

"What?" Adora gasped at her.

"I mean the Alliance," Catra explained as they walked over towards the gate. It was still covered by the iris, but she could see Garshaw on a screen next to the ramp. "Or the Earth parts of it, at least. Like we did on Etheria."

"Uh…" Adora bit her lower lip. "That should be up to them, I think. The Alliance, I mean. And they already have the majority of the generals in Stargate Command, so…"

“Then they should kick out Sidorov.”

“Oh, yes!” Frosta chimed in. “He’s such a pig-headed walrus! I’m a princess and a war veteran, not some baby!”

Catra held her tongue - not because she feared Frosta’s anger; the girl had gotten one free shot back in the war for… reasons. But this wasn’t her problem. She didn’t like Sidorov for entirely different reasons.

“Well, he doesn’t know you.” Adora, of course, considered it her problem.

Frosta scoffed. “That’s no excuse. He knew I am the sovereign of the Kingdom of Snows!”

“Things are different on Earth,” Adora replied. “And, well…”

Fortunately, they reached the screen before Adora could put her foot in.

“Good evening, Grand Councillor,” Glimmer greeted them.

“Good evening, Queen Glimmer. Princess Adora. Princess Entrapta.” The Tok’ra leader looked… well, not too concerned, but she had a good poker face, so that didn’t mean anything. “I see you’ve restored gate access to your home planet.”

Now, that probably means there’s no immediate emergency, Catra thought as everyone was introduced to everyone. Which took a little while.

But after that, Garshaw cleared their throat. “I am calling because we have received disturbing news. Apophis is planning an attack against a planet under the control of a rival in order to frame a third faction for the attack.”

Ah. That sounded… well, kind of smart - and just the sort of thing the Tok’ra did.

“And he is planning to use weapons of mass destruction to ensure this will lead to war - and to hide his involvement.” Garshaw looked grim. “According to our intel, most of the planet’s population will be killed, should he succeed. And, even worse, for such attacks, the general Goa’uld policy is to retaliate in kind.”

Which meant another planet would be razed. And then another. And another.

Damn.

They had to stop that - but that would mess up their planned schedule for the war.

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“Alright. According to your intel, dear old Aphophis wants to frame Sokar for the attack on one of Heru’ur’s garrison worlds so he can then sit back and watch his two most dangerous rivals destroy each other.” Jack O’Neill shook his head. And then the snake would polish off whoever remained - if he waited so long; Jack wouldn’t be surprised if Apophis would attack both once they’re weakened enough just so no one else got to kill them.

“Exactly.” Garshaw nodded.

“And that intel is dependable?” Jack had been on missions based on wrong intel before. He wasn’t keen on repeating the experience.

“It comes from one of our best operatives. They have infiltrated Apophis’s court for years.”

Jack nodded even though that didn’t mean the intel was good - in the spook game, once you discovered an enemy agent, you either turned them or left them in place and fed them bogus information. You could never be sure that the intel was good until after the mission was over. And sometimes not even then. The soviets had gone to great lengths to fool their enemies; even sacrificing a few soldiers or spies of their own hadn’t been beyond

them. And compared to the commie spooks, the snake spooks were worse.

Not that the American spooks were that much better, of course. At least some of them would fit in with either the KGB or the snakes. Like the spook in the room. Jack glanced at Colonel Maybourne and didn't bother hiding his frown.

Maybourne ignored him, seemingly focused on his notes. Jack resisted the urge to make a face at him. If only they were in private…

"So, they're planning an orbital bombardment to wipe out the ground bases, then loot the mines - and probably have some survivors identify their forces as Sokar's. Pretty simple plan," Catra commented.

"As long as they manage to convincingly pass for Sokar's forces, they won't need a more complex scheme," Garshaw said. "Sokar has only recently resurfaced - he was thought destroyed by Ra and his allies after an attempted rebellion thousands of years ago, and he is reviled amongst the other System Lords. Wiping out the population of a planet is exactly what they would expect of him. All Aphophis needs to do is make his force act sufficiently sadistic when killing the majority of the bombardment's survivors and Heru'ur will be fooled."

Jack scoffed. "What a charming fellow." It would take a lot to get reviled by the other snakes.

Then Maybourne spoke up for the first time during the briefing: "Will acting on that intel put your agent in danger?"

Jack clenched his teeth at the man's comment. He should have expected that question from a spook.

"What?" Adora obviously hadn't, though. "We have to stop this attack!"

"Yes!" Glimmer nodded sharply.

Jack looked at the Tok'ra. They had good poker faces, but… Garshaw didn't show any reaction, but Per'sus was glaring at Maybourne. Of course, that could be an act to impress the Etherians - the Tok'ra were well aware of who was the dominant power in the Alliance. Hell, they might even think sacrificing an agent - or setting up this attack in the first place - was worth it if it made them best buddies with the Etherians! Jack was sure that they had done such stunts before, setting up one snake to fight another.

Maybourne, though, appeared undaunted by the anger directed at him - by aliens able to reduce him to a stain on the floor without trying. Of course, they wouldn't do this, but still - many would show some fear faced with that. The spook even had the gall to smile at the angry princesses. "This could be a ploy by Apophis to discover the agent."

"Other sources have verified that some of Apophis's most loyal and capable forces have disappeared," Garshaw cut in. "I doubt he would risk angering two of his most dangerous rivals just to hunt a spy."

"It could still be a consolation prize." Maybourne shrugged. "But the real question is: Should we stop this, risking that the Goa'uld learn of the Alliance's existence, or would it be better if we let the attack happen and let the Goa'uld fight each other for a bit before we reveal that it was a ploy by Apophis? And then let them fight each other some more?"

Jack narrowed his eyes. That was the kind of cold-blooded thinking common amongst spooks. But, a small voice in the back of his head added, the man wasn't wrong - letting the attack happen and then expose Apophis's treachery would do a lot of damage to the Goa'uld. They would tear each other's armies up.

But it would also kill a lot of civilians.

"You want to sacrifice hundreds of thousands of people?" Adora jumped up, her chair clattering to the ground behind her.

“That’s unacceptable!” Glimmer slapped the table with both hands. “We’re not going to let them murder people - we’re fighting this war to save people!”

A crackling sound drew Jack’s attention to his right, and this time, he winced. Frosta was standing, both arms covered to the elbows in gleaming ice - and Jack could feel the cold around the little princess.

He almost quipped about cold rage.

Maybourne finally showed a reaction - he winced. “I’m just asking questions!” he said. “I’m not saying we should let civilians get killed - but it’s my job to ensure that our leaders are aware of the costs of intervening. This is a planning meeting, after all.”

“I think everyone here is aware of that, Colonel,” General Haig spoke up with a frown.

“Yes!” Adora hissed.

“And of the price of our inaction.” Bow looked angry as well.

And Catra looked like she was plotting an accident for Maybourne.

“Colonel, I think we need more data on the status of our various forces. Please start compiling a briefing,” Hammond said. “The president will want it later.”

“Yes, General.”

The spook got up and left the room, and Jack relaxed. A little. Why had Maybourne done this? He had to know how the Etherians would react. Was Kinsey behind this? Was this an attempt to sabotage this meeting in preparation for the Alliance meeting where the actual decision would be made? Not that Jack doubted that they would intervene since the Etherians were unified in this. Had that been the goal? Show that resistance was futile? Or had someone set up Maybourne to take a fall to replace him?

And what was the Tok'ra's game?

Jack clenched his teeth again. He hated dealing with spooks as much as he hated dealing with politics.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, Unites States of America, Earth, January 2nd, 1999

"Here's another argument for the Alliance taking over the Stargate: We could cut the meetings in half."

Adora frowned at Catra's whispered comment, but her friend had a point, sort of - this was the official Alliance planning meeting, and they were going over mostly the same things that they had covered in the first meeting here at Stargate Command.

And judging by Glimmer's snort, her friend agreed. Still, while Adora didn't like rehashing things, she also knew you couldn't just rush everything. And even with shuttles, it took some time to ferry in the Alliance leaders from Earth.

"You're the Supreme Commander," Catra went on. "Just tell them what we'll do."

That… wasn't how things worked either. And Catra knew that. But this was the second hour of the meeting, and they hadn't made much progress.

"...and why is Apophis doing this now?" the German general, Müller, asked. "At the best time to hamper our build-up and make us throw away our plans?"

"No plan survives first contact with the enemy," Jack commented.

Müller frowned. "We both know what Moltke actually meant with that, Colonel. And that's not the point. I'm wondering if Apophis is doing this as a reaction to the preparations of the Alliance - if he knows about our plans."

“Our operatives have not found any hint that would support this,” Garshaw replied. “If Apophis - or any System Lord - would suspect this, they would reach out to their peers, not attempt to play two rivals against each other.”

“His reputation suffered following his defeat at the hands of Stargate Command,” Per’Sus added. “His material losses were minor, but he was personally leading the attack. His rivals will wonder if he had gravely underestimated his enemies, showing a lapse of judgement that might be exploited - or if he couldn’t spare the forces to ensure victory, showing a fatal weakness. This might be his attempt to counter that and present the conflict between Sokar and Heru’ur as a distraction.”

A distraction that would cost the lives of hundreds of thousands of people! Adora pressed her lips together. They couldn’t let that happen! At least none of the Alliance leaders here had suggested that they should let it happen. This Maybourne… She clenched her teeth. How could anyone think like that?

“Why Apophis is doing this doesn’t matter as much as what we’re doing to stop it,” Glimmer spoke up. “We can’t let him murder countless people. We have to stop him.”

“Can we stop him?” another European General, Hansen, asked. “Can we reach the planet with the fleet before his ships reach it?”

“If he sticks to the schedule our agent discovered, yes,” Garshaw said. “The Horde frigates can reach the planet in time to meet the attack.”

“Convenient,” Müller muttered.

“If we send the fleet, we will expose ourselves. The Goa’uld Empire will be aware of our forces - and that we’re about to fight them. We have to keep that in mind,” the British General - Forsythe - said. “We will have a harder time preventing information from getting out than if we struck a target of our own choice.”

“We have to send the fleet - we can’t stop an orbital bombardment with whatever forces we could send through the gate. If we can secure the gate in the first place,” Jack pointed out.

“Maybe.” The Canadian representative, Miller, didn’t seem convinced. He looked at Adora, she realised. “Princess She-Ra, Could you activate the planet’s magic and use the, ah, surge of power to attack the ships in orbit?”

Adora winced. “That was a unique event that can’t be repeated.” And that was a relief! If there were another Heart of Eheria-style weapon… “Not to mention that it would mean that I would have to do this right before the bombardment starts, but after the attackers are in position. The timing would have to be perfect.”

“So, that’s not an alternative. We’ll have to bring the ships out. And the Goa’uld will know those are Horde frigates,” Catra cut in. “They will investigate Horde Prime’s former Empire.”

“But they won’t know about the Alliance. Not right away,” Forsythe said.

“Sooner or later, they’ll find out about us,” Glimmer said. “We didn’t attempt to keep his defeat a secret.”

Of course not! They had spread the news so his subjects knew they were free! Adora nodded.

“We’d still gain some time. It would be better if we could use Goa’uld ships, to make them suspect each other, but…” Forsythe looked at the Tok’ra.

Garhsaw shook her head. “We do not have nearly enough ships for that.”

That was putting it mildly.

“Can we mask the Horde ships as Goa’uld ships?” Miller asked.

Entrapta cocked her head to the side. “We can use false transponders, but camouflaging their visuals is tricky. The frigates are very different designs.”

“We could ambush the attackers before they reach the planet. That would cut down on the number of witnesses,” Catra suggested. “Jam their communications and wipe them out.”

“And make Apophis wonder what happened - if we can pull this off.” Bow nodded.

“It would make him suspect a mole,” Garshaw said. “But any defeat would result in that.”

“Yeah, that’s Dictator 101 - it’s always the fault of traitors, never your own incompetence.” Jack scoffed. “But if you deal with Apophis’s forces in space, that still leaves Heru’ur’s troops on the planet - and what assets they have in space.”

“And they would have the sensors to detect the battle and will investigate it. At least a few scouts will be sent,” Per’sus said. “We will have to deal with them as well.”

“But that won’t take a full invasion. More like a strike by special forces,” Forsythe added.

“So, a space fleet action and a ground-based commando strike. At least, it’s not a Forest Moon,” Jack said.

Adora blinked, then snorted. “The Alliance won that battle anyway,” she pointed out.

“But it was still a trap!”

A number of people were laughing, but they had to explain the comment to the rest of the room. Still, joking aside, they had the start of a plan.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, January 3rd, 1999

"You know, riding a space shuttle to reach a meeting at the other end of the world just doesn't have the vibe of boldly going where no man has gone before," Samantha Carter heard the Colonel comment as they stepped off the shuttle ramp.

"It's a Horde shuttle, not a space shuttle," she corrected him. "And we didn't leave the atmosphere during our flight."

"It's a shuttle and it can fly in space - it's a space shuttle," he retorted.

She didn't have to look at him to know he was grinning. She did it anyway.

"It's amazing, Jack!" Daniel chimed in. "This is revolutionising travel. Or will, once the shuttles spread to civilian use."

The Colonel shrugged. "Making it so you have to commute around the world is not the kind of revolution that we want, I think."

"Once holoprojectors become more common, many meetings won't be held in person any more," Sam pointed out. "And many office workers will be able to work from home. With advanced waldos and matching headsets, even industrial work could be done from home."

"That would be a security nightmare," the Colonel retorted. "Imagine having access to classified material - or weapons - from your home. Go on a toilet break, and come back to find your kid driving a tank across a base as if it was a remote toy!"

"That can be handled with proper computer security," she pointed out as they entered the building.

"The computer security that can defeat human laziness hasn't been invented yet." He grinned again. "I think we'll have meetings in person for a long time yet. No offence, Carter."

“As you say, sir.”

“Want to bet?”

“You want to bet whether or not commuting will still be common?” Daniel sounded surprised.

“Yes, Daniel.”

“But how would you define what counts as common? Or commuting? Especially since with shuttles, what would be considered a long commute might become a quick trip down the block, comparatively. Further…”

“And we’ve arrived!” the Colonel interrupted him. “Welcome to the really official planning meeting! Not to be mistaken for the official planning meeting. Or for the planning meeting. Oh. Sir!” He snapped a salute.

The American general - General Smith according to his tag - standing at the door that had just opened didn’t look amused. “Colonel O’Neill. We’ve been waiting for you to finally arrive.”

Sam half-expected the Colonel to make a joke about traffic, or about generals answering the door - though Sam was sure the officer had been on the way out of the room. But he just nodded. “We came as quickly as we could once we got our orders, sir.”

General Smith harrumphed. “Well, you’re here now. Let’s get this started.”

Sam wondered if he didn’t want them here - technically, they were still assigned to Stargate Command, not the Alliance forces. Though since they were the foremost experts on gate travel and the Goa’uld… They stepped inside.

“Hi, Jack!” Adora greeted them.

“Hey.” Catra looked up from her pad and waved.

Next to them were Netossa and Entrapta, waving as well.

"I saved you a seat!" Entrapta beamed at them. "Glimmer and Bow are meeting the presidents and prime ministers."

Sam nodded, though she had known that already.

"Alright." Adora rose after everyone had taken their seats. "Let's get started. We're here to discuss how to spoil Apophis's attack on PZ-921."

As she spoke, a holoprojector turned on, and the floating hologram of a planet appeared in the middle of the room.

Next to Sam, the Colonel muttered something about Endor, but she tried to ignore it.

"This is the world in question. Heru'ur is using it to grow food for his forces and mine ore for his industry, but according to our intel, it also serves as a Jaffa training camp. The planet's Stargate is located here, and the main mining sites are here and here."

As Adora pointed out the various locations, they lit up on the projection.

"According to Apophis's intel, the base housing the Stargate is fortified and has two squadrons of Death Gliders assigned to it as well as a battery of anti-aircraft artillery." Adora nodded at the others. "We'll have to verify that once we have assets in the system."

"We've sent spy bots to the system, but since it's not close to their current line of advance, it'll take some time for them to reach it. But they'll reach it before our fleet does!" Entrapta chimed in.

"So we will have advance warning in case this turns out to be a trap for Apophis's forces," the British admiral commented.

The Colonel mouthed something that Sam missed.

Adora nodded. "If it is a trap, we'll let them handle Apophis's attack."

That made sense, of course - the Alliance was only intervening to save the civilians.

"But if it's not a trap, we'll have to deal with the planetary garrison. And that's where it gets tricky," Adora went on. "We have to take control of the base housing the Stargate without them calling for help."

The projection zoomed in on the gate location, showing an extensive Goa'uld base.

"I'd rather sneak into a shield generator," the Colonel muttered under his breath.

Sam agreed.

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Bright Moon, Etheria, January 4th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"I've got some experience assaulting and defending similar bases, you know. Well, mostly defending, back when I was a Force Captain, but still, that should be useful, right? And, well - I've received so much help from you, I think I should start helping others in turn. And I don't need my magic power to fight, as you all know."

"We didn't help you and your people because we expect your help in return but because it was the right thing to do. And we are bringing back magic to every planet in the sector anyway, so there's no reason not to start with this planet. And I could do some good on that planet as well - and it's a whole planet full of new plants! And you might need my help if the fields get damaged during the fighting so there won't be a famine as a result."

"You could handle that after the fighting; you don't need to be on the frontlines. And both of you are ruling princesses, unlike us. We don't have other responsibilities, and we need first-hand experience if we are to lead similar missions in the future. With or without powers."

"This sounds like an *adventure*!"

"Sit down, idiot! But as the map shows, the Stargate is near a body of water. I could cover that and grant us a decisive advantage."

"I can freeze the entire lake and form walls around the base. And I can do that without having to have water nearby. Or setting things on fire."

"You lack the experience for this kind of mission."

"What? I've been doing the same things in the war against the Horde!"

"This is a different war."

"War never changes."

Another meeting. If there was one thing Catra didn't like about the Princess Alliance, it was how often they had meetings. And squabbling princesses. And politics, which was usually squabbling princesses. Alright, there were a few more things she didn't like about the Princess Alliance, but right now, meetings were pretty much at the top of her list.

Of course, some meetings were necessary. A number of her operations as Horde Leader would have gone a lot better - or wouldn't have gone off at all - if there had been a meeting where others could have pointed out any flaws with her plans she had missed (and there had been a number of those, obvious in hindsight, but she wasn't going there).

But the meeting she was currently attending? In Sparkles's palace? This wasn't about the best way to deal with a Goa'uld fleet and garrison. Or about potential problems and complications that they might have to deal with in the middle of it.

No, this was just about telling people that they couldn't come along. And the relative novelty of having more volunteers than spots to be filled in a roster had long since worn off. Especially since it looked as if half the princesses would be ready to fight each other if that meant the would get to fight the enemy. "So much for the vaunted power of friendship," she muttered.

Adora shot her a look before speaking up - again - in an attempt to keep order in the meeting. Or peace. "Look, all of you have good arguments, but we can't take everyone with us."

"Why not? Overwhelming power focused against the enemy's weak point is a good strategy, isn't it?" Scorpia asked, slamming her pincers together.

"Not always, as the Horde found out a few times," Glimmer retorted. "And no, we won't bring back magic for this battle."

"What? Why not?" Frosta pouted as she glared at her.

"Because we - I - don't have enough experience with that yet," Adora said. "If I make a… if anything goes wrong, the middle of a battle isn't the best time to try to fix it."

"But you'll do it afterwards, right?" Perfuma asked.

"We're not sure yet," Glimmer told her. "We have to find out more about the planet's situation, the population… Apophis didn't really care about knowing anything about them, other than how to kill most of them, so his intel doesn't cover that."

"We do know that Heru'ur seems to have a better relationship with his Jaffa than most System Lords," Bow added. "He is said to fight at their side and value them as comrades, which Apophis

considers a weakness. But that doesn't tell us anything about the humans on the planet."

"You think they would pick their oppressors over their liberators?" Perfuma stared at her.

"We don't know. The System Lords pose as gods so their slaves obey and revere them. That kind of conditioning is harder to break than slavery," Glimmer said.

Adora didn't say anything, but Catra saw how she tensed. She sighed - the differences between what the Goa'uld were doing and the situation with Third Fleet were obvious, namely that Adora hadn't done anything to be revered as a goddess. Not intentionally, at least. But her lover still blamed herself for it. "Don't be silly," she whispered, letting her tail brush over Adora's calf.

Adoa smiled, though a bit weakly, at her in return.

"Anyway," Glimmer went on. "We'll have to run this mission without our magic powers. Which means those amongst us who are effective without magic will take point."

And that meant Catra as well - not that she would let Adora fight alone, of course. And speaking of her… Catra waved at her lover with a grin. "And those who can use their magic powers anyway."

Adora blushed.

Glimmer nodded. "But you're right about the overwhelming power, Scorpia. We need to not just win, but win decisively, shocking and awing the enemy and their enslaved population to break the Goa'uld's grip on them."

"I can do that!" Scorpia grinned and slammed her pincers together again.

"Yes. You and Adora will be crucial for that. And Catra will help."

“And our bots!” Entrapta chimed in.

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded again. “But we can’t take everyone - that would mean our entire command structure is in this battle. And that would be foolish.” She glared at a few of the princesses for a moment. “Anyway, we’ll use stealth shuttles to land at the three key locations, then hit them right before the fleet action starts. Two will be held in reserve, and Entrapta, Bow and Sam will be present as well to ensure the enemy communications are cut.”

It was a decent plan - Catra would have objected otherwise. Not perfect - they also had to keep a reserve to deal with straggling or unknown elements, and getting those in time would be tricky if they had FTL comms, but it was the best they could do.

She just hoped it would be enough.

“I still want to go!” Frosta said.

“It certainly wouldn’t hurt if we came along,” Netossa added.

Catra sighed as the bickering started again.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, January 5th, 1999 (Earth Time)

For a moment, Jack O’Neill felt as if he was on a base in the United States as he stepped on the ramp of the shuttle that had brought him and his team into orbit and heard the sergeant in charge of the platoon assigned to the same bellow, the man’s voice filling the entire hangar.

“Alright, form up! You’re bunking by squad, so don’t lose your squad leader!”

It sounded like, well, home. Even though the soldiers forming up next to the other shuttle were marines and not airmen.

Then he heard another familiar voice, and the illusion was shattered.

"Hello! Welcome on board the 'Three-Two'! I am Lucius the Faithful, and I will be your guide today! Please follow me to your quarters!"

The clone was far too cheerful for an American base. And far too polite when talking to the enlisted. And far too alien, of course.

Jack glanced at the marines as they lined up. A few of them were staring at the clone, and he hoped it was just surprise at the cheerful tone. If they had sent people who had trouble interacting with aliens, that wouldn't be a fun trip. And not a smooth mission on the target planet, either.

"You heard the man! Follow us! Forward, march!"

The marines marched off - and ran into their first problem when the clone turned out to walk more slowly than they were used to. Well, that was for the sergeant to figure out, and none of Jack's business. Hell, since SG-1 was still part of Stargate Command, he wasn't even officially part of the chain of command of this operation - at least not of the Earth part of it; officially, SG-1 was here on detached duty at the request of the Etherians.

"Hi, Jack! Hi, Sam! Hi, Daniel! Hi, Teal'c!"

And speaking of said Etherians… Jack nodded at Entrapta. "Hello."

"You came!" the princess went on - as if that had been in doubt.

"Yep." Jack grinned and resisted the urge to joke about having an opening in their schedule. Instead, he commented: "So, Three-Two? I expected something like 'Righteous Wrath of the Goddess'."

"Oh, no - all frigates have numbers. Three-Two means this is the second ship of the Third Fleet. Priest wanted us on the flagship, Three-One, but Adora explained to him that the flagship shouldn't serve as a transport or shuttle carrier. I am not entirely sure if

that’s correct - they could launch the shuttles way before the fleet action since they’re stealth shuttles - but Adora insisted.” Entrapta nodded.

“Yeah, I can see that.” Jack wouldn’t have wanted to travel on the same ship as Priest either. Hell, travelling in the same fleet was already a bother, and Jack wasn’t being worshipped as a god by the clones.

On the other hand, neither Anise nor Castaspella was part of this mission, which was definitely a plus in his book. Sure, they were about to launch a landing operation on a planet occupied by snakes, but Jack could deal with Goa’uld and their Jaffa warriors much more easily than with a Tok’ra scientist or an Etherian sorceress interested in his ancestry and progeny. Ugh, ‘progeny’? He must have been listening too much to Daniel and Carter!

“So, everyone is on this ship? Wouldn’t that make it the flagship by default?” Daniel asked.

“I’ve asked the same thing!” Entrapta beamed at him. “But no - the fleet will be commanded by Priest on Three-One. Adora will command the landing operation from this ship, though. Well, until we launch the shuttles, that is. Then I guess the shuttle she’s on becomes the flagship?”

“I don’t think that’s how it works,” Daniel said. “But I’m no expert.”

Why was everyone glancing at Jack? Did he look like he was a Navy Puke? He was Air Force, and the Air Force didn’t have flagships! “Well, it’s not as if we’re doing things by the book - whatever book there is.” Otherwise, Adora wouldn’t get to fight on the frontline. Most of the Alliance brass had protested against that part of the plan, though Jack suspected that many of them just didn’t want to look bad when the Supreme Commander led from the front and they stayed behind. No matter how insane that was. But then, if you were a magical princess that could cut spaceships

apart with their magic sword, it wasn't as insane as it sounded. But still insane.

"Ah." Entrapta nodded as if he had told her something profound. "Anyway, we're all here - well, all those who take part in the attack. They're in the planning room, but I'll show you the lab space for us first!" She beamed at Sam. "And, I guess your cabins, too. Come!"

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"Your chosen companions are on board the assigned ships, Your Divine Highness! The fleet stands ready to depart at your orders!"

"Thank you, Priest." Adora managed not to wince. Her title was She-Ra - or, maybe, 'Supreme Commander' in the Alliance - not 'Your Divine Highness'. And the 'chosen companions' should be the 'Alliance Expeditionary Force'. But she knew from experience that trying to correct Priest would only lead to frustration and waste time.

Time they couldn't afford to waste if they wanted to stop Apophis's plot. "Set out at your convenience, then."

"Your slightest wish is our holy command!" Priest bowed so deeply, she could only see the back of him, then straightened and snapped orders.

Adora watched Earth pass as Three-Two turned and fell in formation next to Three-One, the other frigates of the task force forming a screen around them and the other transports.

They were underway for the Alliance's first operation in the war. She straightened. This would be the official beginning of the war. And it would see them foil a callous, cruel plot by a Goa'uld. A plot aimed at his rivals. In Adora's opinion, that was a good omen.

"And now we wait," Catra commented next to her.

“Even in hyperspace, we have a lot of work to do,” Adora corrected her. Planning the assaults, going over the latest intel - the spy bots should be reaching the target system soon, so they would be receiving more data to go over, which would mean their plans would have to be adjusted and refined, there would be all kinds of problems cropping up that she would need to deal with, and…

Her thoughts were interrupted by Catra elbowing her into the side. “Stop that!”

“Stop what?”

“Worrying yourself into a frenzy!” Catra snorted. “We’ve got this. We’ve done this before - hell, we’ve done entire invasions before.”

“But never one like this,” Adora retorted. And those had been Horde invasions that Catra had done, but she didn’t say that.

“The principles are the same. Which means that the Supreme Commander gives the orders and doesn’t try to micromanage everything.” With a toothy grin, she added: “And if an idiot tries to bother you with small issues, I’ll take care of them.”

Adora blinked. Catra was an experienced officer, but to volunteer for dealing with all the nuisances… Oh. “Are you talking about taking care of the issues or the…” She wouldn’t call them idiots.

“Both.” Catra grinned again. “Can’t have our Supreme Commander stressed and exhausted when the battle starts. Well, maybe a bit exhausted is OK…”

Catra’s gaze left no doubt about what she was hinting at, and Adora blushed. “But…”

“No buts!” Her lover shook her head. “There’ll be enough stuff to personally handle for you, anyway, so you can feel like a proper princess.”

That wasn’t what it was about! Adora pouted at her. Or it was just a small part of it.

But before she could retort, the frigate - the task force - entered hyperspace.

They were on their way to the first battle of the war.

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The Intervention Part 2

Deep Space, On the Way to PZ-921, January 7th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We got the first data from the spy bots in the system!"

Samantha Carter turned away from the preliminary analysis of the latest readouts from her experiment - the lab on the frigate wasn't as good as the one in the Mountain, much less the space lab, but she could still do a lot of work here - and went over to her friend. "What does it look like?"

"Hmm…" Entrapta cocked her head to the side as she looked at the screen held in her hair. "It looks like it confirms the data the Tok'ra shared. At least with regard to the presence of spaceships in the system. Scans show one patrol flight of Death Gliders near the asteroid belt, no other ships."

"Ah." That would fit the intel they had. Of course, if this was a trap by Heru'ur, then any fleet units would be hidden from long-range scans, and while the Alliance had better scanners than the Goa'uld - as far as they knew - they hadn't mounted the best scanners on the spy bots; the chance of them falling into enemy hands was just too great.

"Oh, wait - there's an Al'kesh in orbit around the planet!"

A single bomber? Sam leaned forward and confirmed it. Yes, indeed, a single Al'kesh was in orbit. "That's curious," she commented. But a single ship - and a small one, at that - wouldn't change the equations of the space battle. Not when facing multiple capital ships from Apophis fleet, much less the task force from the Alliance. "Any sign of bombing operations?" If the Goa'uld were dealing with a rebellion on the planet…

"Hmm… nothing going on right now - no explosions. Well, none big enough to show up on the scans. We'll have to get closer to

get more detailed scans of the planetary surface."

That would increase the risk of the bots being detected, but not by much. They weren't true stealth bots, but they had a reduced sensor signature. "Yes," Sam agreed.

Entrapta sent the command, and then they waited. A bit more than six seconds to reach the bot in question, then another six seconds to see it starting to move… the lag was frustrating. Even more frustrating was that Sam hadn't been able to find a solution yet.

Finally, the readings started to change. Of course, it would take longer for the bot to reach a range where the scans were more effective. And it couldn't get too close, or the Goa'uld forces might pick it up.

On the other hand, if they just picked up a bot, with advanced technology, if not too advanced, then they would go on alert, and it might even be enough for Heru'ur to send more ships to the system, perhaps spoiling Apophis's plans without revealing too much about the Alliance's existence… No. Heru'ur was unlikely to send enough ships to deter the attack. Not if he was suspecting spy activities instead of an invasion. And he would be on the lookout for spy bots from then on, making their recon missions more difficult. And as the Tok'ra had pointed out - if Heru'ru found out about the planned atrocities, he might strike back with atrocities of his own no matter whether or not Apophis succeeded in the first place. That was how those things worked. No, they had to stick to the mission.

And speaking of the mission… "Let's call the others," Sam said. The Colonel wouldn't like to wait for the more detailed data, but he would hate not being told at once even more. And Adora and her friends could keep him in line.

"Alright!" Entrapta turned to the main screen. "OK… Aw. I really miss Darla. We should have taken her along." She pouted as her hair handled the intercom.

“She’s rather distinctive,” Sam pointed out. Horde frigates showing up might keep the Goa’uld guessing even if they were spotted, but Darla? A design last used by the Ancients? If the Goa’uld thought they were facing the Ancients, Ancients bent on destroying their empire and way of life, they would likely band together at once, no matter their past feuds. A common enemy did that. And that would make the war much harder to win.

“We could camouflage her! Make her look like… hm… a totally different ship! Or we improve her stealth systems!”

“If we manage that,” Sam replied.

“Well, we’d also have to ask her if she wants to change her appearance. But at least we’ll get good data on the Goa’uld sensors on this mission. Oh! Do you think we’ll get to analyse a captured ship?”

“If we capture one.” Boarding a Ha’tak… Sam pushed the memories that brought up away. They had been desperate, back when Apophis had attacked Earth. This time, it would be different - but it would also be more dangerous. Apophis wouldn’t blow up a ship with him inside, but Sam didn’t doubt that his most loyal Jaffa would rather die and take the enemy with them than allow their ship to be captured.

They had more troops now, but it was still a daunting task, even with Etherian support. Magic didn’t work in space - unless you were She-Ra.

Before Sam could voice her thoughts, the door in their temporary lab opened, and the Colonel stepped inside. “So, I spy with my eye…”

Sam suppressed a sigh. She had heard better jokes from him - he must be more nervous than he let on about the mission.

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“So, Heru’ur has a slightly larger force in space than expected,” Catra summed up the data Entrapta and Sam had presented. “But it’s a single bomber.” Hardly a threat to either Apophis or their own forces. She frowned. “That doesn’t seem much of a concern - though we probably need to take it out to stop them from alerting Heru’ur’s main forces.”

“The question is why Heru’ur would station a single Al’kesh on this planet,” Sam pointed out. “Its main use is to bombard targets on the ground, but Heru’ur controls the planet.”

“The planet’s population might be rebelling,” Daniel suggested.

“Our spy bots haven’t found any sign of combat on the ground,” Sam retorted.

“Unless the population was supplied with advanced weapons, the Jaffa on the planet would be able to handle them,” Teal’c added. “Should they require air support, then the Death Gliders could handle it. Though they would be unlikely to do so - Heru’ur’s soldiers are renowned as skilled and experienced, and highly motivated even for Jaffa; the false god focuses more attention on them than his rivals usually do since he is said to often fight at their side.”

That had been in the briefing, Catra recalled. She hadn’t thought it would be very relevant, though, since they didn’t expect Heru’ur to be present. He would not travel in a single Al’kesh, at least.

“Wow, he sounds like one of the boys,” O’Neill commented with a snort.

Catra narrowed her eyes at him. Princesses did the same - and she had taken the field numerous times when she had been leading the Horde. “A leader’s presence can decide a battle,” she pointed out.

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “Also, Heru’ur fighting at their side would increase his troops’ morale and their motivation, even in training. No soldier wants to slack or fail in front of their god.”

Catra nodded. Not if they wanted to avoid getting punished, at least.

"It is a brave but dangerous tactic," Teal'c said. "Seeing their false god defeated in personal combat would strike a harsh blow against his followers' morale even if he manages to escape."

Which he wouldn't if he ended up facing them. Based on what they knew about the System Lords' technology, Catra wouldn't bet on them if they were facing an experienced princess, much less Adora. And Scorpia would probably just crush the snake, shield and all. And Catra had a few ideas about dealing with him herself, should she get the opportunity…

"Well, if he shows up, we'll do our best to teach him the error of his ways," O'Neill said.

Catra narrowed her eyes at him again. Was that some backhanded criticism of personally leading your force?

If it was, Adora had missed it - Catra's lover nodded with a grim smile. "Yes, we will."

"But back to the Al'kesh," Sam spoke up again. "We still don't know why it is stationed there."

"It might be used as a transport," Teal'c suggested. "Although a Stargate would be faster and more efficient for ferrying both cargo or troops unless the destination lacks a gate - or the Stargate is not under Heru'ur's control."

"So, he might be planning an attack of his own?" Bow asked. "With a single Al'kesh?"

"It's enough for a raid. Their cloaking device isn't going to do much against our new sensors, but against a peer-level opponent…" O'Neill shrugged. "Using a backwater planet like this as a staging area would make OPSEC easier, too."

"We'll have to take it out anyway," Glimmer said. "But as long as it stays out of the atmosphere, we need more firepower than the stealth shuttles can deliver."

Catra frowned. The Goa'uld shields were weaker in a planet's atmosphere, but they were quite strong outside - well, not against a frigate. "We could take a few Horde fighters with us, but that would increase the risk of getting identified. Of course, if it engages Apophis's forces with the Death Gliders, our task force can jump it and destroy it - but if it stays in orbit…"

"I can deal with it," Adora said. "I just need to get to it. And a stealth shuttle can get me there."

"Do you plan to board it, or are you going to cut it apart?" O'Neill asked.

"Destroying quickly is safer," Catra pointed out. That would stop any message from getting out. But…

"We can take it over - there might be prisoners on it," Adora said.

"I guess boarding action it is," Catra said. "Good thing I brought my space suit." Adora opened her mouth, but Catra cut her off. "You're not going there alone. And we've got enough officers to handle the ground targets." Entrapta, Bow and Sam would be busy dealing with any technical issue, but that still left Glimmer and Scorpia. And Jack, in case the other Alliance officers screwed up. He might not be in the official chain of command, but Glimmer could easily give him a field promotion or something to outrank whoever screwed up. It would cause some issues with the Earth generals, but that would be less of a problem than messing up this operation.

Adora was still frowning but didn't seem to have a counter-argument for that.

Catra grinned.

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PZ-921-System, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"The spy bots have detected Apophis's forces," Carter reported.

Finally! Jack O'Neill managed not to blurt it out loud - that would have set a bad example. He wasn't just leading SG-1 here, after all - there was an entire platoon of marines in the shuttle. Sure, they were led by a marine lieutenant, and Jack wasn't in the man's chain of command, but that was only a technicality. The lieutenant's superior officer was back with the frigates of the task force, waiting outside the system, outside sensor range, to deploy once the vanguard in the stealth shuttles had secured the Stargate and taken out enemy communications. And that meant the man might as well be back on Earth - he might even arrive more quickly on the planet if he could use the Stargate, but you couldn't count on that; even if you took control of the gate, the enemy could dial in and block you from using it.

No, with Jack in the stealth shuttle, and him being the highest-ranking officer present, as well as the most experienced when it came to gate travel or fighting the Goa'uld, his advice and suggestions would be taken as orders. And his reaction to, well, anything would be closely observed.

So he yawned and stretched before getting up from his seat in the main hold of the shuttle. "Who won the betting pool? I had 'Apophis tries to be clever and attacks in a straight line from his holdings, to make Heru'ur think Sokar is trying to frame him'," Jack asked.

He was lying, of course - there was no such betting pool. But Carter played along. More or less. "He chose a vector that did neither point back at his territory nor at Sokar's expected holding."

He could hear Entrapta ask, "What betting pool?" over the link to Carter's laptop, but Carter could explain that later.

"Ah, so no one won. What's the status of our fleet?" he asked.

Carter, as usual, had anticipated that and had already done the calculations. “The task force is moving to intercept the attackers. They should be able to engage them in the outer part of the system, sir.”

That, too, had been expected. With hyperspace travel, you couldn’t intercept an enemy on the approach unless you got very lucky and stumbled on them during a navigational break or had their planned route in your computers. So, you had to wait until they dropped out of hyperspace and engage them. And that meant staying near the target, or you might get caught too far out to reach the enemy force before it reached the target.

Still, that meant that Heru’ur’s forces would be able to observe the battle easily. “And that’s our cue!” Jack said, loud enough so all the marines would overhear him. “We need to ensure that by the time the snakes get their butt kicked in space, we control the ground.”

Soldiers, especially the noncoms, needed to know a mission’s goal in case the officer’s got taken out. They had been briefed, of course, but the forces being marines, it was better to repeat the information, in Jack’s opinion. Maybe a few times.

“Alright, men!” the Lieutenant spoke up. “Check your gear and get ready!” He sounded more confident than his age and rank would make you expect - but then, the leathernecks would have sent their best for this mission. Just like the Air Force, Jack added to himself as he watched his team get ready as well.

“Alpha separating,” Carter reported.

Jack nodded. That meant the shuttle carrying Adora, Catra and the boarding force to the Al’kesh.

“Beta, Gamma and Delta en route,” Carter went on right after Jack noticed the acceleration of their shuttle. Beta meant them - the shuttle headed for the Stargate. Gamma with Glimmer and Bow would hit the main mining complex, and Delta would hit the

second mine. Epsilon with Entrapta would stay in orbit as reserves.

Just as planned.

Which meant it was now time for things to go wrong.

"Alright!" And there was Scorpia, back from the bridge. Or cockpit. The huge woman smiled as she took her seat. "Let's crack some snake skulls!" She flexed her pincers, and Jack saw a number of the marines wince.

"Remember, don't shoot the control device!" the lieutenant bellowed. "Also, don't use it as cover!"

Jack snorted. That was good advice. No matter how well it had turned out for SG-1 with their unplanned trip to Etheria, you didn't want to risk a faulty gate forming.

Then the shuttle shook, entering the atmosphere, and Jack clenched his teeth. This was the most dangerous part of the landing. All the stealth in the world wouldn't be able to completely hide the thermal signature of that manoeuvre. And if enemy Death Gliders were close enough… They shouldn't be - the bots had tracked them - but Jack couldn't help worrying anyway.

After a few far too long seconds, the shuttle stopped shaking. Which meant they were now in the lower parts of the atmosphere, slow enough to be again hidden from sensors, now that they weren't imitating a meteor any more.

He slowly exhaled and checked his carbine. Not much longer now.

"Almost down!" Scorpia commented. Her stinger twitched above her head.

"Alpha reached the target," Carter reported, cool as always. "Ready elements of the Death Gliders squadrons are launching."

Which meant they were now on the clock. They had to secure the Stargate as soon as possible - or at least prevent it from dialling out and opening a communication link. FtL communications could be disrupted or hacked, whatever Carter called it, for a time at least, if you had enough tech and juice, but to block communication through a gate, you had to take the gate, or people could radio or even send a messenger through it.

"This is it, kids!" Jack said. "See you at the gate!"

A few marines chuckled at the reference. Daniel pouted, but Jack had expected. Carter and Teal'c didn't react, of course. And Scorpia grinned widely.

And then the shuttle shook once more - they had hit the ground. Then the ramp went down, and the battle started. Heru'ur's Jaffa were sharp.

Jack wasn't the first out of the door, but he was a close second behind Scorpia.

And it was like running behind a tank. Despite the staff blasts flying their way - most splashing against the shuttle's shield - the huge woman charged straight at, then *into* the line of Jaffa still forming up, sending them flying. Literally - Jack saw a Jaffa warrior, armour and all, catch a swing of her pincers and get thrown into the air, high enough to clear the wall behind him.

He put a short burst into another who was lining up a shot at Scorpia, dropping him, then fired at a Jaffa crawling on the ground to get his staff. Another, behind that one, was shredded by Teal'c's staff weapon while Jack opened on two more Jaffa trying to hold a gate in the base wall.

Another Jaffa, screaming like a banshee, went over the wall - no, into a Jaffa on the wall who manning a gun emplacement, both vanishing from sight.

"Teal'c!"Jack called out, pointing up.

A moment later, the whole emplacement vanished in an explosion.

The gates of the base began to close, but Scorpia barreled through the remnants of the Jaffa formation in front of it - Jack thought he saw staff blasts bouncing off her armour - and then threw herself into the gate, tearing it out of its hinges and smashing it on the Jaffa behind it.

Jack emptied his magazine into three warriors left staggering in Scorpia's wake and looked for the rest of his team as he reloaded his carbine. Teal'c was at his side, staff firing at another Jaffa on the wall, and Carter and Daniel were right behind him, with the marines fanning out to cover their flanks.

He turned and raced after Scorpia. The gate's remains were forming a small ramp, and Jack rushed it, shooting a Jaffa caught beneath it through the head, then jumped off, landing in a crouch.

They were in the main yard of the base - in front of the massive stone building housing the Stargate. A dozen Jaffa lay on the ground between the gate and the entrance to the building, some still moving, but more were arriving from both sides as Scorpia was busy ramming herself into the closed and reinforced doors of the building.

Jack switched aim and started shooting the Jaffa reinforcements on the right while he moved up to the building himself, Teal'c, Daniel and Carter, as well as a squad of marines, following him.

By the time Jack reached the building and pressed his back against it, the right wing of the Jaffa had collapsed, and the left wing was falling back under withering fire from the rest of the marines. Jaffa bodies littered the yard, but Jack spotted at least two bodies in camouflage amongst them, both still smoking from the staff blast that must have caught them.

Damn. He gritted his teeth.

"Just a second…" he heard Scorpia grunt as she struggled with the door. "This is tougher than I expected."

"Naquadah-alloy," Carter commented.

That made it super-tough. "We need breaching charges!" he yelled. To go through the walls.

"Just a bit…" The sound of screeching metal cut off Scorpia's words, followed by cracks as she managed to crush the left side of the wall holding the doors in place, stone crumbling under her pincers.

The doors started to shift, Scorpia grinning fiercely while she kept pushing, and Jack grabbed a grenade from his belt. The Jaffa would be ready behind the doors.

As soon as a gap opened, he moved ahead, pulled the pin and threw the grenade through it, then dropped to the ground at the base of the wall. "Fire in the hole!"

A second later, the grenade went off, and dust and smoke billowed through the widening gap, followed by screaming.

A marine ran up to the gap, sticking his gun through it, but before he could fire, a staff blast blew his head off.

Jack pulled out another grenade, intending to throw it through the widening gap, but the other wall was already also crumbling, and Scorpia threw the doors inside with a yell.

Then all hell broke off as she charged inside, staff blasts going left and right before she vanished in the cloud of smoke and dust covering the entrance.

Jack cursed under his breath. He wasn't about to charge blindly - literally - into that. But he couldn't leave Scorpia to face the remaining Jaffa by herself.

"Sir!"

The marine lieutenant drew his attention to the yard - no, to the sky above them. Jack glanced up and cursed.

Death Gliders.

Two of the things, and they were starting an attack run. The stinger team and the bot guarding the shuttle opened up on them. The missile hit one, causing it to whirl out of control and crash somewhere behind the walls, but the other kept going, the shots missing, and rained down blaster bolts on the yard and parts of the wall. One marine carrying two boxes of ammo was caught in the open and shredded by them, machine gun ammo spilling across the ground as he fell.

Then the Death Glider was past them, pulling up to turn around for another go. A second missile chased it but missed. The bot was still firing but didn't seem to be effective. And the Death Glider now had the perfect angle of attack to strafe Jack's entire force.

No choice, then.

"Into the building!" Jack bellowed. "Into the building!" he repeated himself as he started pushing his team into the thinning cloud of smoke.

*****

In Orbit above PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We're on final approach on target. No sign of detection, Your Divine Highness."

Adora licked her lips and took a deep breath upon hearing the clone piloting their shuttle. Good. Just a bit longer, and they had this in the bag. Maybe she wouldn't even have to jump - maybe they managed to sneak up so closely on the Al'kesh, they could surprise them by docking and boarding the ship? Although Entrapta, Sam and Bow had told them that it was unlikely with their current stealth system…

“Target powering up shields, Your Divine Highness! Deploying electronic countermeasures to impede communication!”

Adora gritted her teeth and turned around, looking at the window in the airlock’s inner door. Catra was standing there, scowling at her.

Adora smiled weakly in return. She felt bad about it - a bit - but as great as Catra was, she wasn’t She-Ra. She couldn’t do the same things She-Ra could. Like fighting spaceships in melee. Or disabling them so they could be boarded and examined to find out what their purpose was.

“Opening the airlock, Your Divine Highness!”

The door slid open, and Adora stepped up to the edge. Below her, she could see the planet’s main continent. And to the side, starting to move, was the target - the Al’kesh. She could see the glow from its engines as it tried to evade the shuttle, but it had just begun to move - to change direction - and the shuttle was on an interception course.

She took a moment to watch it move. Enough to know where it would go. Then she pushed, launching herself into space, towards the Al-kesh, sword in hand.

For a brief, brief moment, it was… exhilarating. Like flying. Weightless. Unburdened. Free. Pure joy.

Then she saw the Al’kesh starting to bank and roll in front of her, saw the guns turn to face her and bared her teeth. The first shot missed her, the second she swatted aside with her sword. She cut through the vessel’s shield on the backswing, feeling a tingling sensation on her glowing skin as the force field shattered. Yes!

She hit the hull feet-first, her boots adhering to the metal through She-Ra’s magic. The turret was still trying to aim at her, but two strides brought her close enough so she could grab a barrel, stopping it in its track.

A slash with her sword cut the whole thing apart, the remains blowing up a moment later. She was already moving, though, sprinting towards the main communication array. It, too, blew up after a single swipe with her blade, and she continued to run, to the back of the vessel, her steps hammering the hull. There was the port engine.

Her sword sliced into it in passing - she kept going towards the starboard engine, easily compensating for the sudden heaving as the loss of one engine unbalanced the craft, and the pilot struggled to keep control.

Before the ship could stabilise, though, she reached the second engine, stabbing her blade through its casing, then twisted - and the ship shuddered as its propulsion died.

"Preparing to board the target, Your Divine Highness!" she heard the pilot over the radio.

"Show-off," Catra added with a snort.

But as she watched the shuttle manoeuvre to align itself with the Al-Kesh, the pilot spoke up again. "Incoming vessels on interception course from the surface, Your Divine Highness - Death Gliders."

Adora turned, scanning the planet below her. If the Death Gliders were launching from the surface, then… yes. She could spot four trails of glowing plasma, like miniature comets, angling towards her.

Towards the shuttle carrying Catra.

She clenched her teeth. They were not yet close enough to fire at the shuttle, but that wouldn't take much longer - now she could see the fighters themselves, not just the trails of their engines. Almost close enough… "Engaging!" she yelled through the radio, raising her sword and pushing off again as they started shooting.

They came in too fast, too focused on the shuttle, to react in time when they spotted her glowing form flying at them. She sliced the first fighter in two, both halves vanishing in a fireball behind her, and cut the right wing off his wingman before they started to evade - and she still managed to grab onto the wing of the third, twisting to land on top of its fuselage.

She could see the pilot gasp at her through the cockpit's windows, eyes wide with terror, as she raised her sword, then drove it through the cockpit and him, wrecking the craft as she killed the pilot.

The fourth Death Glider had gone past her, turning around with blazing guns. Outside the range of the shuttle's guns - the pilot was lucky or good. Probably good.

But not good enough. Not nearly good enough to threaten her lover and get away with it.

She jumped off the tumbling wreck, landing on the Al'kesh's hull a moment later, then jumped off again, straight at the strafing fighter. Before the pilot could evade, she ran her sword through the main cannon's casing, and the freed plasma obliterated it instantly.

"Show-off," Catra repeated herself over the radio.

Adora grinned as the shuttle finished docking with the Al'kesh, looking for a way to enter the ship herself.

*****

Gate Area, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Into the building!"

Samantha Carter was already moving, running while bent over, carrying the backpack with her computer in her arms as she passed the Colonel. She entered the gate building behind Teal'c

and stepped to the side as soon as she was past the debris - and the corpses - at the entrance.

The smoke and dust were settling, but visibility was still impaired - she could barely see Teal'c's form as her friend stepped forward, blasting something or someone with his staff.

She didn't bother aiming her own gun - they had a platoon of marines with them. Most of them were already cleaning the rooms of the building with short bursts and grenades. She had other duties.

Sam dropped to the floor and flipped her laptop open. The communication module she had worked on with Entrapta during the last few days was already on, and the utility program she had written was… jamming Heru'ur's comnet. But she could see it wouldn't last - whoever was running the Goa'uld's communication was good. Better than expected. And they had a more powerful machine to use. Sam's laptop was linked to the Shuttle's mainframe, but the connection added just a tiny bit of lag - which could be decisive.

But now she was inside the building. "I need access to a sensor or radio!" she snapped as the Colonel ducked inside, dust and sand from an explosion outside showering him as he threw himself to the ground.

He would have waited too long outside, as usual. She buried the thought as he got up.

"Well, let's find it!" he said.

A loud crashing noise rang through the entire room, followed by an "Oops! Was that supposed to hold?"

"She is a walking tank," Sam heard the Colonel mutter.

"Yes, sir," she agreed. "But she's our tank."

He snorted at that and then moved forward, towards Teal'c, who had crossed the room and was now next to another broken door, peering inside. "Scorpia has secured the Stargate," he said. "But it might be damaged."

The Stargate? Sam's eyes widened. To damage a Stargate, you needed… "The D.H.D.?" she asked as she moved forward.

"The housing," her friend clarified.

That was putting it mildly, Sam realised when she reached the door - the gate was on the floor, facing down. She could see a pair of legs sticking out from underneath it. In a growing pool of blood.

"Well, that's one way to block it, I guess," the Colonel commented.

Scorpia laughed, rubbing the back of her head. "Sorry about that - I heard the gates were very durable, so… I guess the mounts were not?"

Sam checked the rest of the room. Half a dozen Jaffa, dead or disabled. "There should be more warriors," she said. The garrison had, according to their intel, several hundred guards. And this was the key stronghold.

"Yes. We didn't kill nearly enough for the snakes to run out of bodies to throw at us," the Colonel said.

"And Heru'ur's warriors are fanatical - even by the standards of the false gods," Teal'c said, scanning the room as if he expected a secret passage to open. Which, given what they knew about the Goa'uld, wasn't too improbable, actually.

"Well, I only saw those here - and the ones in the entrance hall," Scorpia said.

Sam wanted to look for the missing enemy guards, but she had to stop the enemy communication. She rushed to the D.H.D. The unit wasn't linked to the enemy comnet, but the radio next to it

was - the guards would have used it to communicate through the gate and to announce arrivals to other bases. And while her laptop was a rather jury-rigged combination of Etherian magitech and Earth electronics, it also had a port that was compatible with Goa'uld technology.

She plugged it in - the radio had, fortunately, survived Scorpia's assault, unlike the guard who had manned it, whose broken body lay crumpled at the foot of the wall nearby - and quickly started taking over the Goa'uld comnet. The enemy operator was still active, so he hadn't been in the building here - or he was in a bunker in the base. But now that she had a direct line to the Goa'uld hub, it was quickly becoming obvious that as good as he was, Sam was better. And he would realise it as well. Would he crash the entire network to deny her access?

No, he was… broadcasting 'Avidan' to everyone.

"Gods are just…" Daniel translated. "Is that a battle cry?"

"Not to my knowledge," Teal'c replied.

Then it made no sense… Sam gasped. "It's a code word - he is signalling the guards here and elsewhere, knowing I am reading his comms. And now he's crashing the net," she added.

"Did I mention how much I hate competent enemies?" the Colonel complained before he yelled: "Lieutenant! Report!"

"The enemy outside is falling back, sir!" the marine yelled back from outside the gate room. "They've lost the second Death Glider."

But why were they falling back? They had to hold the building. Or… "They're planning to destroy it!" She quickly focused on her scanner. She hadn't detected any bombs on their approach, but…

Still no bombs. And unless the Goa'uld had found a way to fool Ancient technology enhanced with Etherian magic, that meant

there was no bomb here. Not close enough to affect the gate, at least.

"They must be planning to bomb us," the Colonel said. "Joke's on them - we're taking their bomber!"

That was the logical explanation. Death Gliders didn't have the firepower to destroy the reinforced building - probably not even in a suicide attack. But an Al'kesh had the firepower - more than enough.

But Sam couldn't help feeling she was missing something. Keeping an Al'kesh stationed here just for that? That didn't sound like it would fit Heru'ur's standard procedure.

She ran another scan through the base and the area around it. But once again, no bomb showed up - the entire area to the lake's shore was clear. And any bomb placed further out would have to be too big to be hidden if it had enough power to reach, much less damage the gate.

And yet, what the Colonel would call a gut feeling insisted that she was missing something. Something crucial.

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In Orbit above PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Adora would be OK. She *is* OK, Catra reminded herself as she moved up to the airlock of the shuttle, pushing past the Earth troops - British Special Air Service. Which weren't part of the Air Force despite the name. But Catra was used to such weirdness - it was actually tame compared to what some princesses came up with.

"Ah, Ma'am…" One of them opened his mouth.

"I'm not going in first, don't worry," she cut him off, showing her fangs. "She-Ra's the one who can shrug off blasters." Her suit

might withstand a volley, Entrapta did great work, but she wasn't betting her life on it if she didn't absolutely have to.

"And fly naked through fucking space," another soldier muttered.

"Smith! Shut up!" the officer in charge yelled.

Catra chuckled, then pulled her shock rod from the holster on her back. The engine noise was dimming slightly - they would dock any moment.

Then the shuttle rocked, a few soldiers having to grab the bars on the walls to keep standing. And there was the metallic noise of the magnetic clamps engaging - they had touched down on the Al'kesh's hull.

A moment later, the airlock opened, revealing the smooth hull of the enemy bomber. "Breaching charges!" the officer bellowed, but his demolition man was already moving forward and placed the device Bow had designed on the hull.

"Clear!" he yelled, rushing back - behind the shield-bot stepping up.

A beep followed as the shield sprang up.

"Blow it!" Catra snapped.

The charge went off, quickly melting through the armoured hull. For a brief moment, Catra wondered what it would have done to people - and if Bow had ever used the trick arrows from which he had claimed to have developed this on Horde soldiers.

Then the breaching charge finished, and the hull had a hole wide enough for two soldiers at once.

Or one shield bot moving forward. And not too soon - the bot had barely stepped inside the Al'kesh when the first staff weapon blast splashed against the shield. Obviously, Heru'ur's warriors were

living up to their reputation. The average Horde troops wouldn't have reacted as quickly.

But the Jaffa were not facing average Horde troops. Catra grinned, flashing her teeth, as she moved forward, next to a soldier carrying a light machine gun - an Earth weapon. Two staff blasts hit the shield right in front of her, causing it to flicker.

But she had spotted the shooters' positions and flicked her rod at them. She hit the first one, lightning crackling over his armour as he went down, frozen with his muscles cramping up. The one next to him was riddled with the bullets the earth armies loved so much, falling against the wall and sliding down, blood flowing from several holes in his armour.

It seemed the armour-piercing ammunition worked as well as SG-1 had claimed.

The rest of the boarding team was now also inside the bomber, half of them going down the other side of the hallway, guns firing. They would secure the armoury and bomb bays.

"Alright, move it!" Catra snapped. "Bridge team with me!" She turned, moved forward, to the next corner, then peered around it. Three Jaffa were half-hidden behind struts, blocking the way. And one of them… She jerked back, and two staff blasts whizzed past her head as she dropped to the ground and rolled around the corner, catching the shock grenade the third had thrown with her rod's blast halfway in its arc.

It went off, lightning filling the hallway for a moment, and Catra pushed off, somersaulting away and behind a strut herself.

That let the soldiers with her round the corner and open up, and the three Jaffa went down - though so did one of the soldiers, half his arm blown away.

"Medic!"

Catra grit her teeth. They couldn't stop. She dashed forward, over and past the dead Jaffa, through another intersection, and caught a pair of Jaffa coming out of a passage to the side. Before they could react, she jumped, pushing off the wall, then the ceiling, and came down between them, lashing out with claws and shock rod.

Her left hand's claws went through the armour of her target as if it weren't there, tearing his throat out, while her shock rod hit the chest of the other, sending him to the floor in convulsions.

She dashed on, running on all fours, rod between her teeth. Speed was of the essence now.

A blast went over her head - another Jaffa, laying in ambush. She jumped over the next blast, and then she was inside his reach, jamming the shock rod into his side. One more down.

The door to the bridge was locked, but that didn't stop her. A few slashes with her claws cut it to pieces, and she side-stepped the volleys from inside. At least three Jaffa, judging from the number of blasts.

She clenched her teeth. She didn't like doing this, but… They had a nice choke point. And the soldiers were still coming up.

She gripped the grenade on her belt - a 'flash-bang', pulled the ring away and lobbed it inside, then slapped her hands over her ears.

The explosion still hurt, of course. But not enough to stop her. She dashed inside, where the four Jaffa were still reeling from the grenade going off. Her shock rod put one down, then she rolled beneath a swing from the next before lashing out with her feet, her claws slicing through the Jaffa's leg muscles and tendons. He collapsed, and she finished him off with a stab of her rod.

The two others were recovering - but as they were turning to face her, the rest of the bridge team arrived, and both went down in a hail of bullets as she rolled behind the closest console.

“Watch your fire!” she snapped as she rose. “But good work.”

She quickly thumbed her communicator. “Bridge secure!”

“Engine and bomb bay secure!” the Lieutenant confirmed.

“Already? I just found the airlock!” Adora complained over the communicators.

“Slowpoke!” Catra shot back. But before she could tease her lover further, the spy bot that had followed the boarding team and connected to the computers started beeping.

“What? A bomb went off?” Catra gasped. “Where?” Had they missed one?

Another beep.

“On the surface?” she hissed. “Where?”

The screen lit up, showing the location. But that was… far from the Gate area. None of the landing teams should have been near it. Heh, it was in the lake there!

Catra blinked. The bomb was in the large lake that ended in a narrow bay right at the gate area. And she remembered the briefing about explosives and water from the Salineas campaign.

Cursing, she hit the button on her communicator, switching to the general frequency. “Beta! Watch out! You’ve got a flood wave incoming!”

*****

The Intervention Part 3

Gate Area, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Beta! Watch out! You've got a flood wave incoming!"

Jack O'Neill froze for a moment when he heard Catra's warning over the radio. "A flood wave?" They were near a lake, and…

Carter gasped and started typing quickly on her laptop. "The bomb that went off - it was in the lake! Sir, we've got a localised tsunami incoming!"

"What?" Daniel went over to look at her laptop as if he was an expert.

"What is a tsunami?" Scorpia asked, leaning forward to look upside down at Carter's screen. "Oh, that's a big flood wave. We heard about them in Force Captain orientation. Once. Or was that a briefing?"

"The bomb went off at the other end of the lake, underwater, and caused an underwater landslide - and the form of the lake is creating a tsunami aimed at this base!" Carter spoke in that tense, clipped tone she only used when they were in mortal danger. "And this structure won't resist the power of the wave. We need to get to higher ground - but the wave will hit the shore here in four and a half minutes!"

The area around them was pretty flat.

Carter kept talking. "We can dial out and evacuate through the gate, provided we can get it upright and stabilised! We just…"

Jack cut her off and thumbed his radio. "Beta shuttle, lift off and land at the entrance to the gate building - we need to be gone in three minutes." He almost felt bad upon seeing Carter blink and then blush. For all her brilliance, sometimes she missed the easy solution. "Everyone else - head to the entrance right fucking now

for evac! We've got a tsunami incoming!" He could only hope none of the marines was trying to be stupid. They should know how deadly a tsunami was.

"Good call!" Scorpia nodded. "So… do we take the gate with us?"

Right. Jack had to remember that she could carry the damn gate as if it was a heavy backpack or something. "Take the D.H.D. with you," he said, already moving towards the doors. The gate would survive this. The D.H.D. was more fragile.

"Alright!"

Jack reached the broken door and saw that the marines in the building were already rushing towards the entrance. "Squad leaders, check no one's left behind!" he yelled. Probably not necessary, but better safe than sorry. "Move!"

"I'm moving!"

He turned and blinked. Scorpia had misunderstood him - she was carrying both the gate and the D.H.D.! He opened his mouth to tell her to drop the gate, then stopped. Despite the weight, she was moving at a decent clip.

"Three minutes left, sir!" Carter was behind the princess, followed by Daniel and Teal'c.

"Noted," Jack replied. "Move!" He clenched his teeth. They could make the entrance easily - but would the shuttle be in time?

But as he approached the main gate, he could hear the shuttle's engines - they were coming in to land.

He still reached the landing spot before the shuttle touched down, but they had the ramp lowered already - and kept hovering instead of actually landing.

"Go! Go! Go!" the Marine Lieutenant shouted. He looked like he wanted to push and carry his men up the ramp.

Jack knew the feeling.

“Two minutes!”

Jack thought he could already hear the roaring water. But that might just be his imagination.

It shouldn’t take too long to get inside the damn shuttle, but two marines were wounded and had to be carried.

“One minute!”

Still plenty of time, Jack told himself. “Get inside!” he told his team.

Daniel jogged past him up the ramp, followed by Carter. Teal’c didn’t move.

Jack knew better than to urge his friend on. He watched as Scorpia, grunting, stepped onto the ramp - and winced at the sound the metal made under the weight of the woman and the gate. But the Ancients made solid shuttles. Solid anything.

“Watch out - don’t get crushed - pull your legs back!” Scorpia yelled, panting, as she stumbled up the ramp.

“Move! Give her some space!” Jack heard the Lieutenant yell.

“Sir!” Carter stood at the top of the ramp, next to the swaying Scorpia. “The wave’s moving faster than predicted! It’s already here!”

Too early. “And that’s our cue!” Jack rushed up the ramp. “Let’s go.” Don’t look back. Don’t look back.

He looked back anyway, and his eyes widened. The wave was taller than the walls of the base. And coming in way too fast.

“Lift off!” he yelled as Teal’c passed him, both of them barely inside the shuttle. “Pull the ramp in!” He barely heard himself over

the noise, but the pilot didn't need to understand him anyway.

The shuttle started to fly up just as the wall facing the lake was crushed by the wave, concrete and metal parts flung around by the water, and Jack had to grip a handlebar to keep his balance when it suddenly turned.

They were still too low - the wave was too fast. Too high. It would crush them in a…

The engines screamed, and Jack was almost thrown out of the shuttle, only the closing door stopping him - painfully - when the shuttle boosted away, a moment before the water reached the gate building - and swallowed it.

"I'm sorry, sir!" Carter said as he got up, "My projections were faulty - I didn't account for the narrowing width of the lake, which sped up the wave, and so…"

He shook his head. "Stop it, Carter. You did your best. No one's perfect. And we've made it out alive."

At literally the last second, but they'd made it.

"So… can I put this down now?"

Oh, for… He turned around and winced. Scorpia was still holding the Stargate - and her strength was the only thing keeping the gate from crushing a few marines.

Damn.

*****

In Orbit above PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and yes, everyone got out - we didn't lose anyone to the wave. Over."

“Thank you.” Adora sighed with relief. Jack sounded a bit annoyed for having to repeat himself, but she had to make sure that no one had died in the flood. Losing people in the fighting was bad enough, but this?

She looked at the screen with the feed from Jack’s shuttle - beta shuttle - again and winced. She had only seen pictures of the gate area on the planet, not the best pictures at that, and holo-projections, but even so, the scene she saw on the video was shocking. The entire base was pretty much gone, replaced by a stretch of murky water. What buildings hadn’t been swept away by the waves were buried in the mud. Only the gate building was still standing. Somewhat at least. It looked as if the front had collapsed, or maybe the foundations had given way there - that part was also under water, while the roof of the rest was still visible. It must be full of mud inside… “Do you need assistance? Over.”

“Not at the moment. We achieved our objective. Over.”

Next to her, Catra chuckled. “Technically, he’s correct - since Scorpia carried the gate and the D.H.D. into the shuttle before everything was buried in water, we *have* taken control of the planet’s gate.”

She was right, but the entire base was gone. That hadn’t been planned. Of course, they were planning to create a new base underground anyway, but…

“Remind me not to needle Mermista as much as I used to,” Catra commented, leaning a bit forward and cocking her head.

Against her will, Adora snorted. “I don’t think Mermista could do this,” she said.

“I bet I could make her mad enough to manage it,” Catra retorted as their shuttle stopped its approach and hovered next to the other shuttle.

Adora wasn't sure about that but she couldn't rule it out. "Everyone got out," she said. That was one of the good things about this.

Catra nodded. "And the enemy didn't get a call for help off."

"As far as we know," Adora reminded her. She pushed a button on the console, and the image on the screen changed, showing buildings on solid ground, built at the foot of a cliffside, a number of them smoking. Bots were walking around between the buildings, and the ground was covered with bodies. The feed was from a bot as well - Adora could tell from the angle of the view.

Catra whistled. "Wow, that must have been bloodier than I expected."

Adora once more was forced to agree. Glimmer's report had been on the short side - 'The mining complex is under our control. No active enemy forces remain in the area'. "The Jaffa must have fought to the death." Horde troops - Hordak's Horde troops - would have retreated or broken long before… before dying like this.

And they hadn't died alone - she could see at least two bodies wearing Earth uniforms on the ground. And there were three wrecked bots. Had the Jaffa managed to focus enough staff weapons on the bots to overload the shields? Or had they used heavy weapons?

"Looks like Entrapta needs to work on adapting Emily's shields for all the bots," Catra said. "How's the third site going? Did they manage to clear the mines?"

Adora winced. The third force, led by a French officer, had been forced to land a bit further away due to the terrain, and by the time they had overrun the base there, the Jaffa had fallen back *into* the mines. And digging them out of there… "We might have to reinforce them."

“You mean, you want to go and do it yourself,” Catra corrected her.

Adora blushed a little. “I can shrug off their weapon fire,” she pointed out.

“You can’t shrug off the mines collapsing and the mountain falling on you,” Catra retorted. “And if they’re willing to flood their base, they’re willing to blow up their mines. Send bots into the mines.”

“The mine shafts aren’t large enough for the bots,” Adora told her.

“Then send smaller bots.” Catra stared at her.

“We don’t have combat-rated bots that small,” Adora said. Her lover knew that - Catra just didn’t want her to enter the mines. Adora pressed her lips together. There were slaves inside the mines. Hostages. They couldn’t starve the Jaffa out. Or bury them inside the mines. They had to go in and save the hostages. And she was the best person for this mission.

Catra kept glaring at her for a few more seconds before she sighed. “Alright. But we’ll do it smartly. With the Tok’ra tunnelling tech, after scanning for their explosives.”

Adora nodded.

“Your Divine Highness!” Priest’s voice filled the shuttle’s bridge. “We have destroyed both enemy forces in space! Although I am sad to report that even when their ships were crippled, the enemy crews refused to surrender and preferred to destroy their own ships to deny them to us. Our secondary objective failed. I take full responsibility, Your Divine Highness, and await your judgement!”

Adora closed her eyes and sighed. That was… She shook her head. “You did well, Priest. I am proud of your task force.”

Next to her, Catra snorted again. “He’s very hard on himself.”

"Thank you, Your Divine Highness. But we could have done better. I await your divine insight."

Oh, no! Adora really didn't want to debrief Priest right now. "Ah, I am sorry, but… we have a… situation on the planet that requires my personal attention. Secure the system and await further orders!"

"Your wish is our holy command, Your Divine Highness!"

"Only you would prefer to assault a suicidal enemy holed up in a mine ready to collapse over debriefing your subordinate," Catra commented, shaking her head.

Adora didn't answer. Instead, she called up the feed from the second mining complex and started looking for the best way to deal with that.

*****

Near the Gate Area, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter took a - subtle - sigh of relief when Scorpia finished manhandling the Stargate out of the shuttle and put it down on the ground - facedown. Not just because of the danger that the gate would shift during flight and crush the troops near it, but mainly because if anyone had dialled in, the vortex forming would have wrecked the craft - the shuttle simply wasn't big enough to survive a gate activation.

"Whew. Adora makes it look so easy." Scorpia wiped some sweat from her brow, then flexed her pincers. "I guess I need to work out more," she added with a chuckle.

Sam couldn't tell if the princess was joking or not - Scorpia had a self-deprecating streak, at least in Sam's opinion. Maybe low self-esteem, but Sam didn't know her well enough to tell. So she shrugged. "She's She-Ra." That covered a lot, in her experience.

“Right.” Scorpia grinned. “But we did well.” Then she looked at what used to be the base housing the gate, and her grin vanished.

Sam understood the feeling. And shared it. They were a good distance away, on the closest hill in the area, and so had a good view of it. The base was simply gone. Wiped away and buried in water and mud. Irradiated water and mud, at that, according to Sam’s sensors. It was relatively weak as far as radiation went, but still a concern for long-term exposure.

“Cleaning this up will take some time,” she commented. And a lot of effort. “And it has to be done quickly because when it dries up, the winds will carry radioactive dust to untouched regions.”

“Yeah.” Scorpia nodded. “It might be easiest to unlock the planet’s magic and have Perfuma grow some plants over the area.”

“That would help contain the radioactivity,” Sam agreed. The right plants would keep the soil together and stop it from becoming a radioactive version of the Kansas dustbowl.

“We still have to dispose of the plants once they sucked up the radiation, of course,” Scorpia went on, “but we’ve got some experience with that in my kingdom.” She chuckled again. “The Horde wasn’t very environmental-friendly, so we had to clean up a few dumps like this. Maybe worse. Perfuma helped so much...”

Sam ignored the slight twinge of envy that she felt after seeing the sappy smile that had appeared on Scorpia’s face and made a mental note to check if Perfuma actually could create plants that ‘sucked up’ radioactivity. If she could, that would be a game changer for several regions on Earth - and the war, of course. “This has to wait until we’ve secured the planet, though,” she said.

“Yeah. But we’ve wiped out the space forces, and all that’s left on the ground are the Jaffa holed up in that mine. And scattered guards and the patrols caught too far away to join the battle, I

guess." Scorpia shrugged. "And with the gate secured, we pretty much control the planet."

"There might be more such bombs hidden on the planet," Sam pointed out. "Entrapta's running a thorough scan from orbit." They should have done that from the start, but… 'You can ask me for anything you like, except time', as Napoleon had put it. Still, Sam wasn't looking forward to the debriefing of the mission. The things she had missed…

She glanced at the Colonel, who had dropped all pretence of not being in charge and was ordering the troops around to secure the hill until the troop transports arrived. He would claim it was his fault, but Sam should have spotted the bomb before it went off. Should have expected something like this.

Although… Why did they put a bomb into the lake? It was a very convoluted way to self-destruct. Was it meant to wipe out an attacker and leave the base mostly intact? That wouldn't really work out; the mud would harden quickly, and clearing it out would probably take as long as building a new base. Although the Stargate and D.H.D. would survive a flood. A bomb powerful enough to wipe out a base would destroy the D.H.D. and might even damage the Stargate.

Sam wasn't convinced, though. The whole plan went against what they knew of Heru'ur. They'd have to interrogate the prisoners about this. Too bad they hadn't caught the Jaffa giving the signal for the bomb.

Though with their magic scanner, the chances of the Jaffa managing to hide from the Alliance were very, very low. They could track their symbionts and most technology from orbit. There would be no guerilla war on the planet. Not unless the local slaves turned out to be a lot more loyal to the Goa'uld than expected.

She noticed the Colonel walking over to them, Daniel and Teal'c in tow, and straightened.

“So, who’s up to play tunnel rat?” he asked with a wry grin when he reached them. “I hear we have some fascinating caves to explore. Or to make, I guess.”

Sam nodded. “Yes, sir.” Despite her blunder, she still was the best choice to handle the technological side of the assault on the mine. Except for the tunnelling part; that part would be handled by the Tok’ra, of course.

“I’m up for it!” Scorpia flexed her pincers. “Let’s finish this so we can focus on helping the people!”

To Sam’s surprise, the Colonel didn’t make a cynical joke about it. Then again, he had just been checking on the casualties of their force - both the wounded and the dead. Even though it wasn’t his fault that they had died, he would be blaming himself for it anyway.

*****

Secondary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“This wouldn’t work if that were a Naquadah mine - well, it would not work as well. We probably could calibrate the sensor to ignore Naquadah ore, unrefined Naquadah, but it would be quite the challenge since Goa’uld larvae have so little Naquadah in them, so it would still be a little tricky to discern them from the background. But since this isn’t a Naquadah mine, we can track all Jaffa in the mine shafts! So, that’s a good thing, kinda - even though having a Naquadah mine would have been great.”

Catra nodded at Entrapta’s explanation. Of course, if this world had Naquadah deposits, it would have been defended with far more forces, and Apophis would have picked an easier target, so it was all hypothetical anyway. What mattered was that they knew where the Jaffa holed up in the mine shafts were.

She studied the holoprojection in front of her. It showed a maze of twisting tunnels where they followed the ore veins. And a

smattering of red dots - the Jaffa guards who had made it into the mines. They were concentrated at several choke points. An obvious deployment, but that didn't make it any less of a pain to deal with - if you had to attack them from the front. But there were also a number of Jaffa on the lowest levels. "Did you detect any explosives?" she asked.

"Yes! A lot, actually - but since this is a mine, that's kinda expected, right?" Entrapta turned to Emily and nodded, and the projection floating in front of the bot changed, orange dots appearing at various locations. A lot of them. And spread out. "That's not ideal," she commented. There were three concentrations of explosives, but the rest of the stuff was scattered all over the tunnels.

"Yes," Adora agreed. "It would be easier if they had concentrated all the explosives in one spot."

Catra also wondered if the Jaffa took the explosives from the central magazine outside when they were falling back or if they had another magazine in the mine. But that was an academic question right now.

"What about their hostages?" Glimmer asked. "If we can get them out, the Jaffa can blow themselves up as much as they want."

"That would ruin the mine!" General Soissant objected.

"It's a single mine on a backwater planet," O'Neill retorted. "And we already control the main mining site on the planet."

The one Glimmer and Bow had secured, while the French-led fore had failed their objective at the secondary site. Something Catra wasn't tempted to bring up.

"The hostages are our priority," Adora spoke up. "Where are they?"

"They're gathered at the deepest part of the mine," Sam explained as blue dots lit up on the projection.

“That allows them to kill them all if we launch a frontal assault,” Soissant said.

“Or they just moved them there to get them out of the way,” O’Neill pointed out. “They might not see them as hostages - the Goa’uld wouldn’t care about the lives of slaves, and the Jaffa might not be aware that we aren’t working for a rival System Lord.”

That was a good point. But it also meant that the Jaffa might kill the slaves in case this turned into a siege. Or to deny them to the enemy. “Well, that makes it more urgent to get them,” Catra said.

“We can reach that, but it will take a while,” Martouf told them. “We could also dig tunnels to all the other locations, but we only have two tunnelling devices. So we would have to dig the tunnels one after another, leaving a thin wall to break through when we are ready.”

“And if the Jaffa detect a tunnel, they’ll know what’s up and start taking countermeasures,” Catra said. “And they’ll expect more tunnels.”

“Do they have the sensors or scanners to detect that?” Glimmer asked.

“They might hear us tunnelling,” Soissant suggested. “Even if they didn’t have any sensors.”

“And they might have sensors to detect cave-ins,” Bow added.

“We didn’t detect any such technology,” Entrapta said.

“The snakes don’t really care much about their slaves.” O’Neill shrugged. “Though they would care about cave-ins holding up the mining.”

“Anyway, even if we focus on the hostages and write off the mine, the explosives could bring down the mountain on us while we’re getting the hostages out. So, we need to deal with the explosives

and the hostages," Catra summed up. In the Horde, that kind of mission would have been assigned to expendable troops. Or a budding rival you wanted to get rid of.

"So, three main sites for the explosives, one for the hostages. And we have to hope they don't detect us before we can surprise them." Glimmer shook her head. "It might be better to return magic to the planet - I could teleport inside, dropping off soldiers. Perfuma could use plants to take control of a shaft. Frosta could freeze the explosives. But even with magic, I don't think we can reliably take control of all the explosives without the Jaffa managing to blow up at least a few of them - they aren't stupid and will be ready for an attack."

"We can jam electronic detonators," Sam said. "That would only leave manual detonators."

Which wasn't really reassuring. Catra was sure that Heru'ur's guards were willing to die if it took their enemies with them.

Adora leaned forward, frowning at the projection, then turned to Entrapta and Sam. "Can you build a shield generator that can protect the hostages as long as we need to get them all out?"

"Uh…" Entrapta scrunched her nose.

"I doubt it," Sam replied. "Not if the Jaffa have wired the mine to collapse. If the tunnel is safe, maybe." She looked at Martouf.

"We can't guarantee that," he said. "If the explosives have enough force to cause a localised earthquake…" He trailed off with a grimace.

So, that was a bust as well. Damn. Catra clenched her teeth. No matter what, it looked like they would have to take a huge risk. And that meant Adora would take the risk.

"I have an idea," Bow spoke up with a hesitant smile. "But we need Glimmer's magic for it - and those spy bots."

Oh? Catra cocked her head to the side.

"You have an idea?" Glimmer asked, smiling at him.

"Yes." He nodded and leaned forward. "So… we have samples of the explosives they use in the mine. All we need is…"

*****

Jack O'Neill peered at the bottom of the hole in front of him, checking if the explosive was prepared correctly. It was - Jack had done it himself, after all. Then he moved back to the trenches, well, back to the reinforced laboratory-slash-observation post, as Entrapta was calling it. "It's ready."

"Goody!" Entrapta beamed at him. "Sabotage Bot Three, go!"

One of the spy bots gathered in the room beeped and left. Jack could see it outside, moving towards the hole in the ground.

"It should work," Bow said. "The lab trials were successful."

"Nothing beats a test under field conditions," Catra said. "Except for actual field testing, of course. And Kyle."

Adora chuckled at that, but none of the others did, Jack noticed. An obvious in-joke.

"Three's approaching the test site," Carter reported. On the screen next to her, they could see the bot's point of view as it moved into the hole, then sprayed the explosive down with the solution Bow, Carter and Entrapta had cooked up in less time than it had taken the ground forces of the task force to disembark and set up forward bases.

"Good work, Three! Now get to safety!" Entrapta said.

The bot's feed changed as it climbed out of the hole.

As soon as it was clear, Carter spoke up: “Attempting to detonate the explosives.” She pushed a button, and the scene changed to show the feed from the camera they had installed next to the explosives. “Detonating.” She flicked a switch, and Jack saw a small spark on the screen.

“Detonator was activated, but the main charge remained inert,” Carter reported. “Test successful.”

“Impressive as always, Captain,” Jack commented with a smile as Entrapta and Bow cheered.

“It was Bow’s work, sir,” she immediately deflected. “He already had the base solution for a fire-suppressant arrow; we merely adapted it to the specific explosive, produced sufficient quantities of it and modified spy bots to deploy it.”

And she honestly thought that whipping all this up in a few hours wasn’t impressive. Jack chuckled - and caught himself before he patted her shoulder. Moving to parade rest, he nodded. “Good work anyway, Captain. I’ll go check up on the rest of the force.”

“Yes, sir.”

“I’ll come with you!” Adora said, joining him as he approached the door.

“Can’t leave the generals unsupervised for too long.” Catra, as expected, followed her, as did Glimmer.

“You never know what they get up to,” Jack agreed.

They walked over to the centre of the field base that was springing up around them - well, the part of it that was above ground, at least. Which was mostly composed of fortifications, a heavily guarded entrance to the bunker being grown below them, and storage buildings that would turn into decoys as soon as enough underground storage room was created.

And tanks and other heavy weapons, of course. “The cats are out in force,” Jack commented as they passed a platoon of Leopard 2s placed to cover the road leading to the landing site of the transports. Two Gepards were behind them, covering the skies. They weren’t really necessary, given the sensors and guns on the transports near them, but Jack approved of covering the bases. They were at war, after all.

“Hm?” Catra cocked her head at him.

“The Germans name their tanks after big cats,” he explained.

“They’ve got taste,” Catra replied with a grin.

Glimmer snorted at that.

The guard troops at the entrance here were a mix of French and German soldiers, straightening as they approached. The officer in charge even saluted them - which you shouldn’t be doing in the field. Then again, Adora was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance and quite distinctive in her outfit.

Inside, they found the familiar chaos of a headquarter in the middle of a huge exercise - or an invasion. Officers and noncoms coming and going every which way, people talking into dozens of radios and phones, people staring at maps and screens… well, also holoprojections in this case. And the walls were distinctively alien-looking.

But it was still a NATO standard field headquarters at its core. “Seen one, seen them all,” Jack muttered under his breath as they approached the generals’ corner.

The generals, too, straightened when they spotted Adora. “Supreme Commander,” General Duchemin greeted her. “Commander Glimmer,” he added with a nod at the queen.

“Generals.” Adora nodded back. “The tests were successful. All that’s left before we can assault the mines is the tunnelling equipment and magic.”

Jack caught the German general wincing a little but he couldn't tell whether it was because of the magic or the fact that Adora had made it clear before that she would be leading the assault. Duchemin, though, smiled. "Very good. We are proceeding on schedule and will soon commence mopping up operations - motorised recon units are already shadowing the remaining enemy forces." He pointed at the screen behind them, where red symbols showed the locations of the remaining Jaffa thanks to Entrapta and Carter's magic scanner.

"Good. What about the civilians?" Adora asked.

This time, the French officer grimaced a bit. "Our soldiers are keeping away from them. They seem wary of our presence, and we have focused on deploying our force and dealing with the remaining military threats before further pursuing this."

"They shouldn't be a factor for the operation," the German general added. "Besides, Dr Jackson has volunteered to take the lead on handling the civilian population and is currently talking to the local village."

Jack blinked, then suppressed a sigh. He should have expected this, but he had been so busy with handling things until the invasion force had landed, then handing over command to the generals and following the preparations for the assault on the mines.

Adora, though, beamed. "They're in good hands, then!"

"Yeah, right," Jack added, trying to sound sincere. His friend was great with people. Most of the time. Sometimes, though, he tended to mess up. Jack hoped this wasn't one of those times.

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Outside the Former Gate Area, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Alright. We're ready."

Adora took a deep breath as she heard Glimmer over the communicator. The bots were ready. Glimmer was ready. It was time. They couldn't really wait much longer, anyway - the longer they waited, the greater the risk that the Jaffa would do something drastic. As Jack had pointed out, they might not even be aware that the slaves were hostages as far as the Alliance was concerned. If they decided that they couldn't afford to feed them…

She took a step forward, away from the shuttle waiting behind her, and stared at the huge field of mud in front of her.

"Don't worry," Catra said next to her. "Even if you mess up, you can't actually make things worse here."

Adora slowly nodded, though she could make things worse if she made a mistake. Or lost control. The power of magic returning… She almost shuddered at the memory. But this was the best plan they had come up with. Much safer than trying to use the magic to deal with the Jaffa in the mine. If she made a mistake there…

"You won't mess up," Catra told her. Full of trust. Full of love.

Adora clenched her teeth and forced her doubts away. She couldn't dwell on that. Wouldn't. She was She-Ra. She had the duty to save people. And she would.

She raised her sword and closed her eyes. Focused. She felt the power. The magic. Reached out. Connected.

She gasped as the magic of the planet filled her. It wasn't the same as Earth's magic, but still somehow like it. So much power! Trying to flow through her, like water trying to get around a dam. And she…

Gritting her teeth, she cut the pattern holding the magic back. And shuddered with relief as the pressure lessened - the magic was returning to the world.

But she still was filled with power. She felt as if the magic would burst through her skin any moment. And if she didn't focus, didn't control this…

She pointed her sword at the muddy field below her. Focused. Thought. Imagined. The mud. The water. The radiation contaminating, poisoning both.

Eyes blazing, she moved her sword from one side to the other, a beam of light reaching out, sweeping over the area.

She barely heard Catra whistle next to her as she directed the magic into the water. Into the mud. Into the very earth. Cleansing. Healing. Changing.

When the pressure, the power from the planet's magic, was gone, she opened her eyes and took another deep breath, shuddering slightly.

The radioactive muck covering the area was gone. As were the ruins of the Goa'uld base. Replaced by vast fields filled with plants ready to be harvested. Wheat. Corn. Lentils. There were orchards full of trees with ripe fruits on them. Apples. Olives. Oranges. Rows upon rows of vegetables. As far as the eye could reach.

Catra snorted. "You know, if Perfuma was the envious sort, this would make her mad."

Adora turned to look at her lover. "She didn't get mad at the space plant."

Catra grinned, flashing her teeth. "I know. That's why I said if she was the envious sort." She reached over and patted Adora's back. "Well done!"

Adora nodded.

"Of course," Catra went on, "if any of the locals here saw that, they'd worship you as a goddess of fertility."

Adora smiled. “That’s why we were doing this here.” There were no settlements near the former base. The planet’s population, except for the Jaffa, had been concentrated at the mining sites and the farming villages feeding the miners. And any Jaffa left behind had died in the flood.

No, she wouldn’t be worshipped as a goddess just for returning magic to the planet and putting the spillover magic to use. “Let’s get back to the mine,” she said. “We’ve got people to save.”

Catra nodded. “And enemies to defeat.”

*****

Secondary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Everyone was ready when they returned to the mining site. Glimmer met them at the landing pad. “There you are!”

Adora smiled at her. Glimmer seemed to be bursting with energy.

“Bet you teleported a few times just for the heck of it,” Catra said with a grin.

Glimmer frowned at her, but she was blushing just a little. “It would have been irresponsible not to test it before we start.”

“Sure, sure.” Catra folded her hands behind her head as she stepped down the ramp.

Adora nodded at Glimmer with a smile. She understood her friend - it must be terrible not to be able to use the power you had grown up with. Adora herself hadn’t grown up with magic powers, but she remembered the time she had lost her sword and hadn’t been able to turn into She-Ra, back in the war. She had felt terrible. Weak. Useless. A failure. Glimmer was so strong to be able to bear that whenever she travelled in space - or visited planets without magic!

They walked over to the area where the force for the mission had been gathered. Dozens of spy bots, fading in and out of view as their stealth systems engaged. Soldiers with stun weapons, in case the slaves were too cowed or indoctrinated to let themselves be saved. Medics.

And Adora's friends - Bow, Entrapta, Scorpia, Jack, Sam and Teal'c. No Daniel - he was busy with the local people, or so she had been told.

"Hey! Done with turning the ruins into a space plant?" Jack grinned.

Adora rolled her eyes. "Everything worked as planned," she told him. And he had known she hadn't been planning to create another space plant. She turned to look at Sam and Entrapta. "Any changes?"

"No. They haven't moved from their positions, except for a few swapping positions," Sam reported.

Adora nodded. "Good. Let's go then."

"Let's teleport!" Glimmer corrected her with a grin. She turned to look at the holoprojection in front of Emily.

This was tricky, Adora knew that. Glimmer had never been inside the mines. And as good as Entrapta and Sam's scanner was, it couldn't fully replace seeing the actual location. But Glimmer was very experienced with her power, and the holoprojection was detailed enough and to scale so she could estimate the distances. It would be safe enough for Glimmer.

At least, that was what she had told Adora. Of course, Glimmer wouldn't lie - not about this - and Bow didn't seem worried, or not more worried than would be normal.

Adora still worried, of course. Teleporting into an unknown location full of enemies and explosives *was* dangerous. And

Martouf was doing their best, but the tunnel couldn't really get close to the mines until the explosives were dealt with.

Glimmer nodded to herself, then took a deep breath. "Alright. I've got this." She turned to the bots. "Who's first?"

A few of them beeped, one warbled, then two skittered over to her, their stealth coating flashing briefly.

"Trust your sensors!" Entrapta told them.

"OK. Now, this might be a bit disorienting…" Glimmer reached out to grab a leg of both bots, closed her eyes - and disappeared with the usual popping sound and sparkles.

Adora looked at the holoprojection. Three new, green dots appeared. Two split off and started moving. And the third…

Glimmer reappeared with a wide grin. "Next!"

Two more bots moved toward her. Glimmer grabbed them and teleported away again.

A minute later, a dozen bots had been transported. And Glimmer looked a little winded.

Catra shook her head. "Bit out of shape, huh?"

Glimmer glared at her. "Teleporting into new locations is not as easy as you think it is."

Catra shrugged. "As you say."

But Glimmer straightened. "Let's go down the tunnel so we're ready."

They moved to the small bunker they had erected to hide the tunnel entrance - they would have to clean that up afterwards, Adora reminded herself - and then began their descent. Sam and Entrapta stayed behind, updating them on the bots' progress.

"...Five and Six have reached their targets… Good bots! That's one stash neutralised! And Seven has gotten to that tiny stash at the air shaft! Yes!" Entrapta cheered.

"No movement of the Tok'kals," Sam added. That meant the grenades the Jaffa carried.

The enemy had half a dozen of those, of the explosive variant, but they were spread out - and one of them, or even two, wouldn't be able to collapse a tunnel, much less the mine. But if they were gathered together… Well, as long as they were used as grenades, their main danger would be when used against people. Such as hostages.

"And that's the last one!" Entrapta announced as they reached the end of Martouf's tunnel. *"All explosives have been neutralised! Good work, bots! And Bow!"*

Bow smiled, looking relieved - even though no one would have blamed him if anything had gone wrong.

"Enlarging the tunnel to connect to the hostages," Martouf announced.

Adora watched the tunnel grow in front of her. It was impressive how smooth it was - the earth and stone seemed to meld into walls. Smooth but slow. No, that was unfair - it was moving quite quickly, for a tunnel. But slowly for an attack. It would take several minutes to reach the part of the mines with the hostages. Minutes in which anything could happen. The Jaffa could decide to kill the hostages. Or…

"Oops! Seven was detected!" Entrpata called out over the communicator.

Or they could spot a bot. Adora clenched her teeth, then looked at Glimmer. "Get me inside!"

"And me!" Catra moved to her side.

Glimmer didn’t hesitate and grabbed both of them.

A moment later, they reappeared in a different tunnel - inside the mines. “The hostages are this way!” Glimmer whispered, pointing down the tunnel illuminated by Adora’s glowing sword before she disappeared again.

Adora started running, Catra right behind her. She had to duck a bit in spots - the tunnels were narrow and twisted as they followed the ore veins. But people were counting on her, and she wouldn’t let them down.

“Two Jaffa ahead of you!” Sam announced over the communicator.

Behind Adora, Catra hissed.

Adora gritted her teeth and sped up. She rounded the next corner and ploughed straight into a guard, slamming them into the rough wall behind them. She followed up with a blow to the head that took the helmet off and knocked the Jaffa out - or killed them. Adora didn’t stop to check but whirled around, sword rising…

…and saw Catra withdraw her claws from the bleeding ruin of the other Jaffa’s throat as he slumped over.

Nodding, Adora continued to run down the tunnel.

“Two more - no, three, they’re gathering at the choke point,” Sam told them.

“Got it!”

Staff blasts greeted them, but Adora struck them with her blade and charged through the explosions. A swing of her sword cut the closest Jaffa in half. Another screamed: “Goa’uld!” right before she cut him down as well.

“Goa’uGH!”

The third also died screaming, disembowelled by Catra’s claws.

They raced on.

"They've tried to detonate the explosives!" Sam reported a few seconds later.

So soon? Why? Adora asked herself. But she had almost reached the prisoners. Just a bit further.

"They keep yelling 'Goa'uld'," Catra told her as they dashed down the tunnel. "They must think you're a Goa'uld."

"Oh." That was…Was that why they were trying to blow the mines? To kill a Go'auld?

Dim light and more screams greeted her before she found an answer. Scared screams - they had reached the hostages!

Adora lifted her sword above her head. "Do not fear! We're here to save you!" she told them. "We will get you to the surface, to your families! A tunnel will open here soon!"

"It doesn't look as if they believe you," Catra commented as the people shied away from them.

Adora kept smiling at them. How could she make them trust her? Oh! There was one holding his arm, grimacing. He must have been hurt. Perfect! She pointed her sword at him. She could…

…terrify him, she realised when the people started screaming, many falling to their knees and bowing. Pleading.

"I am healing you!" she snapped - and sent magic power at the man.

He yelped when the magic reached him, then broke off, looking stunned.

"You're healed," Adora told him.

He hesitantly touched his arm, then started to move it, a shy, hesitant smile appearing on his face.

The people started whispering, no longer shying away from her. Yes!

Then everyone knelt, their foreheads touching the ground.

No!

Catra snorted behind her. "Good work, idiot."

"At least they trust us now," Adora shot back. And the tunnel would reach them soon. So…

"Oh! The Goa'uld at the main shaft are… they're dropping their weapons!" Entrapta told them over the communicator.

Were they surrendering? Adora started to smile.

Then Entrapta went on. *"They're manipulating their weapons - the power fluctuations… but…"*

"They're overloading the power cells!" Sam cut in.

What? That meant…

"They're blowing up!"

Adora didn't hear the explosion, but she thought she felt the earth tremble. But that was all. Whew.

"The main shaft is collapsing!" Sam sounded terse over the communicator.

And then the earth was definitely shaking.

*****

The Intervention Part 4

Secondary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter stared helplessly as the main shaft of the mine collapsed on her screen - and on the holoprojection in the middle of the command centre. "It's just the main shaft," she whispered. "As long as the mining tunnels hold… if the shockwave isn't too powerful…" The uppermost tunnels were fine so far. And below…

"That's a shockwave!" Entrapta cried out.

Screaming filled the communicator - the hostages inside the mines, Sam realised. As miners, they would know about cave-ins.

Her heart sank. Whether the Jaffa had planned this - she couldn't tell; the explosives had been improvised, after all - or had just gotten lucky, the shaft's collapse had struck the hardest on the lowest level; she could see the tunnels there shake on her screen. And those weren't tunnels made according to Earth's safety standards. Those were tunnels dug by slaves for a cruel master who didn't care how many of them died as long as he got his ore.

Sam saw a small side tunnel starting to cave in as the supports splintered and clenched her teeth. Her fingers flew over the keyboard as she zoomed in. "I need a structural scan!"

"On it!" Entrapta replied. "Uh-oh! That's not good - there's an unstable layer on that level. And the pressure…"

Another side tunnel was collapsing - no, collapsed. And that caused more shifts. More pressure. More tremors. This was a cascading cave-in.

The screams turned into coughing - the dust cloud caused by the collapse of the shaft must have reached the hostages. More, hoarse screaming.

"Everyone, into the tunnel! Run!"

That was Catra.

"The entire area is shifting - now tunnels upstairs are collapsing!" Entrapta yelled. "And that softer layer of rock is…"

It was giving way under pressure. Filling the tunnels beneath it. And that destabilised the more solid rock layers. At least there was no water in those layers.

"Move, damn it!"

"Everyone, into the tunnel!"

"Come on!"

Some of the hostages were starting to run. But not all of them - and a few were running in the wrong direction! They must be panicking.

"Get them out!"

"Come back!"

And some were… on their knees, praying? Sam shook her head and focused on her screen. There had to be something she could do, other than watch as the mine caved in one tunnel at a time. "How's the Tok'ra tunnel doing?"

"It's holding - the shock wasn't too strong at the start. But I don't think it will hold forever - the pressure from the collapsing tunnels is building up, and check that area there!"

A strand of hair whipped over Sam's keyboard, enlarging an area above the hostage tunnel. And that was… Sam paled.

"You need to get out!" she screamed into the communicator. "The whole area is going to cave in - including the evacuation tunnel!" Her friends were down there! The Colonel was down there!

“Oh, no!”

Sam froze for a moment. The entire area above the tunnel was shifting now.

“Adora!”

*****

“Adora!” Catra screamed at her love. Who had changed her sword into some huge support-beam-thing which she was using to *hold up the ceiling*.

“Run!” Adora snapped. “Get out!”

“You can’t hold up the entire damn mountain, you idiot!” Catra screamed - and dragged one of the kneeling idiots up and pushed him towards the tunnel. “Run!”

“Glimmer can get me out once everyone’s safe! Ugh!”

Catra blinked through tears as she watched her love strain, then turned around. More soldiers, O’Neill at their head, were literally dragging the stumbling slaves out of the tunnel. She kicked another who was not fast enough, pushing the numbskull towards the tunnel.

The earth shook again - another tunnel collapsed. Dust and pebbles rained down from the trembling ceiling.

Catra coughed once - she needed to bring a breath filter if she was ever doing this again - and looked around. The dumb hostages were finally leaving. But…

“There are some who ran away!” Adora yelled. She was straining to hold up the ceiling, Catra could tell. But the idiot wouldn’t leave while others were in danger.

“Glimmer!” she snapped into the communicator. “Can you get those who ran into the mine?”

"On it!"

Sparkles was on the job. Catra looked around. Most of the hostages were now in the tunnel - but they were too slow.

Another tremor, another tunnel gone. She could hear the rock grinding against each other, even over the yelling and screaming. And she could see cracks appearing in the smooth walls of the Tok'ra tunnel.

"How many are left?" she yelled.

"Sec… three… no, one, Glimmer got two. One is left!" Entrapta replied.

That would be an acceptable loss. But not for Adora.

"Where are they?" Catra asked.

"Glimmer got them!"

Finally! Catra rushed towards Adora. "Everyone's out of the mine!"

"But not out of the tunnel!"

Oh, for…! Catra clenched her teeth - the idiot was right. The evacuation tunnel might not withstand the collapse of this tunnel.

"Run!"

Never! Catra shook her head. "I'm not leaving you!"

"You can't do anything here," Adora pressed out through clenched teeth. Her knees trembled, buckling - no, she straightened with a grunt, pressing back against the ceiling. Rocks and more dust were now dropping steadily, and the ground was constantly shaking.

"I can be with you," Catra retorted.

The look she got from Adora was… both full of love and desperation.

Catra smiled back as best she could. “I’m not leaving you, you dummy!”

“Idiot!” Adora’s next words were lost when she groaned. This time, she didn’t manage to straighten - she was slowly giving ground.

Catra swallowed. “It’s getting close here,” she said into the communicator.

“Run!” Adonra snapped.

“I wouldn’t make it out,” Catra told her.

“No!”

A dust cloud filled the room - part of the main tunnel had collapsed. Catra coughed once more.

As did Adora. And she almost lost her footing, grunting again as she pushed back. This was…

Catra hissed. If she had to die here, then she would…

Glimmer appeared next to them. “Hands!”

Catra reached out, hugging her - and Adora.

A loud crack filled her ears, and the ground started to give, and someone screamed, and…

…she was on ground that didn’t move, under the open sky, blinking, coughing, crying. Outside. Next to Adora. Alive.

*****

Fresh air. Jack O’Neill took a deep breath as soon as he reached the exit of the tunnel. And then another. And another. He might be

in the best shape ever since Adora had healed him, but racing up a shaking, collapsing tunnel from the bottom of a mine to the surface would have left anyone panting.

“Adora and Catra are safe.”

Anyone but Teal’c, Jack amended his thought. But the Jaffa was kind of cheating, with his alien body and symbiont.

But his friend was right - Jack could see the two - three, couldn’t forget Glimmer - crazy girls on the ground in front of the bunker. Alive and healthy. Though they looked pretty… tired. Maybe exhausted. Adora was sitting on the ground, holding onto Catra in her lap, while Glimmer was lying on her back, arms and legs spread. She must have overdone it with the teleports, Jack realised.

He shook his head as he approached them, trying not to show how relieved he was. And how he wanted to scream at all of them so they would never do anything like that again. “We had a headstart, yet you beat us to the finishing line. Took a shortcut?”

“Did you just call Glimmer short? She’s kind of sensitive about that,” Catra shot back without releasing Adora or even looking at him.

“I am not!” Glimmer protested, also not looking at him.

“Glimmer!”

“Adora! Catra!”

“What were you thinking?”

Bow, Entrapta and Carter had arrived. Jack schooled his features as he turned to face them. Well, face Entrapta and Carter - Bow went straight past him to hug Glimmer. “I think we both know what they were thinking,” Jack told Carter with a wry grin.

“Yes, sir.”

“I think it’s obvious that they wanted to save everyone,” Entrapta said, her head cocked sideways as she looked at Jack. “And according to our data, they did.”

“But it was a near thing,” Martouf chimed in. He, too, wasn’t out of breath at all. Damn snakey cheaters.

“Indeed. But they succeeded.” Teal’c inclined his head.

“Our tunnel was close to collapsing in its entirety,” Martouf pointed out. “The geological conditions were more dangerous than we anticipated.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “We didn’t take the different types of rocks in the mine into account. And we kind of missed that the Jaffa could use their own weapons as explosives.”

Improvised explosives, but still. Jack nodded. “Yeah. Someone forgot to tell them that they aren’t allowed to do that.”

“Oh?” Entrapta blinked. “Who?”

“The Colonel’s joking,” Carter explained.

“Ah.” Entrapta nodded again. “Is that his coping mechanism, as Daniel explained?”

Jack reminded himself to ask Daniel what exactly he was telling people about Jack. Some stuff was private. A lot of stuff, actually.

Carter glanced at him instead of answering.

He sighed. “A good joke can relieve tension. And we’re all very tense here.” And explanations ruined jokes.

“Ah, I see!” Entrapta nodded and made a note on her device or something.

“And yes, we’ll have to address those things in a proper debriefing,” Jack added. “So we can do better next time.”

Carter winced. “Yes, sir.”

Jack suppressed a sigh. Carter was blaming herself. Even though she wasn’t to blame. Nobody was perfect, but she came pretty close. And she was a physicist, not a geologist. That they hadn’t had a geologist on call - or called one - while preparing to storm a mine wasn’t her fault. That was a failure of her commander. Meaning Jack. Sure, he was just a Colonel, but he had been involved in the planning from the start - and he had the ear of the Etherians. They would have listened to him.

“Well, we know we need to keep Adora on a leash,” Catra commented. “Or she’ll risk her life again. And get herself worshipped as a goddess.”

Jack blinked. That was… Oh. He snorted as he saw the saved hostages stare at them - at Adora - from a distance, some craning their necks to keep looking even as soldiers guided them away to reunite them with their families. “Well, she just held up an entire mountain to save everyone,” he said. “That’s bound to make people mistake you for a god.”

“Indeed. The mythology on Earth has similar deeds attributed to various deities, I believe,” Teal’c commented. “And no false god would be able to equal this.”

That almost sounded as if Teal’c was calling Adora a real goddess. But he would know better than that, wouldn’t he?

Adora groaned and closed her eyes. “I am no goddess!”

Well, at least she knew it.

“And you aren’t a Goa’uld,” Catra added. “Anyway, mission accomplished. The hostages are saved, and the enemy was crushed - and it was their own fault.”

Jack had to chuckle at that, and she grinned in return.

"They thought I was a Goa'uld, and they were willing to die to kill me." Adora shook her head as she got up, and Catra slid off her. "We didn't expect that kind of fanaticism."

"Heru'ur has some of the most loyal Jaffa amongst the System Lords," Teal'c said, "but I would not have expected such dedication. Things are, or at least were, different under Apophis."

Jack nodded. "Yeah. Let's hope this guy remains an exception. If we have to re-enact the War in the Pacific, things will get messy." Messier than they already were.

"At least his human slaves do not display any such loyalty," Teal'c pointed out.

That was a small consolation. Jack clapped his hands together. "Anyway, how about we move this to a nice, private debriefing room, once Glimmer and Bow come up for air?"

The two didn't even have the grace to blush. Kids these days. And now Catra was glancing at Adora as if this was a challenge or something. Was that how Hammond felt with SG-1?

"So…" Jack trailed off when he spotted a signals officer heading towards them.

"Sir! Ma'am!" the young man snapped. "We've received a radio transmission from the main mining site! The, ah, representative of the local population has requested a meeting with Supreme Commander Adora to discuss the planet's status."

Jack blinked. He hadn't been aware that the planet's population had a leader - they had been slaves until a few hours ago. And now they wanted to 'discuss the planet's status'? He would have expected them to keep their heads down and play it safe, not… He blinked.

And then he sighed. Of course!

"Daniel, what did you do?"

*****

Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

The base at the primary mining site - the one Glimmer and Bow had taken without issue, Adora reminded herself - looked a lot like the one they had just left at the secondary site. As she stepped out of the shuttle, Adora could see soldiers putting up walls - both earthen and prefabricated steel - around the base area.

And the guards were as alert as the ones back at the other mine, she noted as they snapped to attention at her approach. Just different uniforms - American and British, here. Of course, there were still Jaffa scattered on the planet, but the ground troops had started to hunt them down.

"I thought we didn't salute in the field," Catra whispered, though a little too loud to be discreet, next to her.

Adora gripped her lover's hand a little tighter - and suppressed the urge to hold her tightly and scold her again for staying with her in the mine - and nodded at the soldiers.

"It's debatable if this still qualifies as in the field," Jack commented behind them. "Though I generally say that it counts until a PX opens in the base."

"PX?"

"A military store," he explained. "Where soldiers can buy goods and services. Like food and uniforms, for example."

"You make them pay for their food and uniforms?" Catra asked with a snort. "If we had done that in the Horde, we'd have had a rebellion on our hands. Well, a second one."

While Jack protested that it wasn't like that, Adora smiled even though she didn't like being reminded of that time. "Anyway," she

said, “let’s go see what the representative of the people here wants,” she said, nodding at the aide waiting for them.

“And what Daniel did this time,” Jack added under his breath as the officer led them towards a big tent.

“I am sure Daniel didn’t do anything bad,” Adora told him with a frown.

“Tell that to the generals,” Jack retorted.

“Oh, I will.” Adora nodded firmly. Daniel was smart and honest. She trusted him to do the right thing.

Jack blinked, then snorted. “Right. Forgot for a second that you can do that.”

“Forgetting stuff is a sign of old age,” Catra told him.

“Of course, you’d think I am old.”

Martouf kept silent, Adora noted. Well, they might be thinking about where they would be using the tunnelling technology here.

The guards at the tent also stood at attention when Adora and the others arrived, and the aide opened the tent’s entrance. “The Supreme Commander of the Alliance!” he announced.

Inside, Adora saw a few officers - Generals Bryce and Percival, and their aides - Daniel, who was smiling a little sheepishly at them, no, at Jack, and half a dozen people who were obviously locals judging by their clothes. All of them bowed, but they didn’t fall to their knees.

“Sadiki, leader of the people of the planet,” Daniel introduced the man in the middle of the group.

“For now,” the man added. “We couldn’t ask the other settlements, but ours is the largest.”

“Which means that this is not a diplomatic meeting with the actual representative of the local population,” the American general, Bryce, said with a frown.

“Sadiki represents the majority of the people here,” Daniel retorted.

“It looks like he’s trying to steal a march on the others and get himself installed as the leader before anyone else,” Bryce shot back.

It sounded as if they were repeating an argument, Adora thought. She focused on Sadiki. He looked at her, though he wasn’t quite meeting her eyes.

She smiled at him and the others. “Hello. I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. Please call me Adora.” She transformed back as she said so. Catra snorted next to her, and Adora didn’t have to glance at her lover to know she was rolling her eyes. But there was nothing wrong with being friendly, and she didn’t want to tower over those people. “We have saved the hostages in the second mine,” she added. “But the mine collapsed when the Jaffa hiding there blew up the main shaft.”

“Oh.” Sadiki, who had been staring at her, seemed surprised, then slowly nodded. “The mine is lost then?”

“We can’t tell yet,” Martouf cut in. “We need to scan the area and determine if it’s safe to tunnel back down. If it is, we can open it quickly.”

“You can do that?” Sadiki seemed surprised.

“We have advanced *technology*,” Daniel told him.

“And *magic*,” Catra added.

Right. Adora nodded. “Yes, I have restored magic to your planet. So, those of you who have the talent will be able to learn how to do magic.”

“Magic…” Sadiki blinked.

“Yes.” Catra grinned. “Also, she used the surplus magic power to turn the flooded site into fields and orchards. You might want to send people there to harvest the goods.”

Adora suppressed a frown. Yes, Catra was right, and the locals would have to harvest the fields before it went all bad, but she didn’t have to make it sound so… deity-like.

“I see.” Sadiki bowed again, more deeply this time. As did the others. “We thank you for this. With Heru’ur’s forces gone, we were not sure how to feed everyone - we have fields and farming villages, but not enough to supply everyone. We depended on food delivered by his Jaffa.”

“Yep, that’s one way to keep control of a population,” Jack said.

“The Alliance can and will supply you with food and everything else you need,” Bryce cut in.

Sadiki glanced at the general, then at Daniel, before he looked back at Adora. “Does that mean you will be taking over our world?” he asked, a bit hesitantly.

“What? No!” Adora shook her head. “It’s your world! We came to liberate you, not to conquer you.” They were the Alliance, not the Horde!

“Although in order to ensure that Heru’ur won’t return, we’ll have to station troops here,” Percival added. “We will need bases for them.”

“I see,” Sadiki repeated himself. “And will you take control of the Stargate?”

“Only until you can safeguard it yourselves,” Adora reassured him. They were here to save the people, not to take over.

Sadiki smiled. But Bryce was now openly scowling. And glaring at Daniel.

*****

Forward Base, Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and so, although this is merely a preliminary geological analysis, and experts in the field need to confirm it, it seems that while the lower parts of the mines have completely collapsed, the upper tunnels won't suffer the same fate. Not without further tectonic activity, natural or induced." Samantha Carter nodded as she finished her report.

"So, basically, if you want to mine more ore, you need to do a thorough geological check beforehand - some of the rock there is more like gravel," Entrapta added. "And that's not very stable. Although with the right technology, you can deal with that. We've got a few ideas on how to strengthen tunnels, but they require some testing."

"Thank you." General Percival nodded. "So, the Secondary Mining Site won't be operational for the foreseeable future - and not at all unless we invest considerable resources."

"Yes, sir." That was what Sam had just explained.

"Resources the local population cannot afford," General Bryce added, "and which wouldn't be justified by the expected return in ore production."

Sam noticed that General Percival glanced at his colleague with a peculiar expression. The British officer was a bit hard to read, but she didn't think he approved of Bryce's comment.

"That doesn't matter, though," Entrapta said. "The mine got destroyed because of us, so we need to fix it. That's how things work."

Sam had to suppress a smile at her friend's comment. It was a simple but, fundamentally, correct view of the morality of the situation.

Percival nodded, though Bryce scowled. "We are at war. Resources are limited. We can address this once the war's won," the American general said.

"We just need more data," Entrapta retorted with a slight frown. "And we've got the time for that."

"And this will result in useful experience for future operations," Sam pointed out. The Tok'ra tunnelling technology was a key component for assaults and invasions, after all. And Bryce knew that. So, what was going on?

"Indeed," Percival said. "Although we'll also require permission from the local government for such actions."

That was a surprise. Sam hadn't expected the local population to have a government already. Much less one that was apparently a potential obstacle for Alliance operations, at least if she interpreted Bryce's scowl correctly.

"Well, we can easily ask them." Entrapta beamed. "I doubt they will refuse our help - it won't cost them anything, after all."

"I wouldn't be so sure," Bryce scoffed.

Sam was missing something. She had been rushed into this briefing after arriving at the base here, and so she hadn't been able to talk to her team and her Etherian friends yet. And she had a gut feeling that she really needed to speak with the Colonel and Daniel about this.

As soon as she was dismissed by the generals.

*****

“So, you’re hiding from Jack?” Catra asked while she dug through an MRE for the candy parts. She was lounging on a fold-out chair, which was surprisingly comfortable once you contorted yourself just right, especially since the design, unlike the more padded armchairs like those in the palace back in Bright Moon, allowed her tail to swish freely. Ah, chocolate! She pulled the bar out and dropped the rest - curry, which was meh - on the floor of the meeting room she had commandeered.

“I’m not really hiding,” Daniel protested. “I’m just… catching up on my paperwork until Sadiki and his people return. Jack can easily find me.”

Catra snorted. “Sure, sure.”

“Besides, wouldn’t that mean that you’re hiding as well?” Daniel looked at her over the rim of his laptop.

She grinned back. “I’m not hiding. I told Adora I would get something to eat instead of trying to keep myself from clawing the colonialist generals.” And she had done so loudly enough for at least one of them to overhear her.

Daniel smiled at that. “I see.”

“You’re not the only one who has issues with installing a ‘protectorate’,” Catra told him while she ripped the wrapping off the bar. As if she wouldn’t realise what the result of such a policy would be.

“It’s official Alliance policy that any bases require the agreement of the local government.” Daniel deflected.

“Official Alliance policy you told the local government about.” She bit the bar in half and chewed, savouring the taste. “A local government that was formed shortly after you made contact with the settlement here.”

“In order to make an informed decision, you need to be informed.” He looked at his screen instead of at her, but she could

see his lips twist into a smile. “Everything I did was in line with official Alliance policies.”

She swallowed, then snorted. “Yeah. And if not for the princesses backing that policy, you’d be in trouble with the leadership.”

“That’s speculation,” he retorted.

“Well, good work,” she told him, flashing her fangs.

He didn’t reply, but she could see his smile grow larger.

But then the door to their room was opened, and Entrapta and Sam entered. “There he is! Just like the scan showed!” Entrapta said, beaming.

Daniel blinked. “You used your scanner to find me?”

“Ah, so you admit you were hiding!” Catra chuckled.

“You were hiding? We thought you were lost!” Entrapta said, blinking.

Catra doubted that Sam had believed that.

“I’m just working on my report.” Daniel pointed at his laptop.

“And hiding from Jack,” Catra added.

“So, it was you who organised the local government and told them how to approach the Alliance.” Sam shook her head.

“All in line with official Alliance policy,” Catra told her. “As agreed by all the big leaders back on Earth.”

Daniel nodded. “Pretty much, yes.” He didn’t look as confident as before, though.

Sam sighed. “And what did the Colonel say about this?”

Daniel grimaced. “Ah, we weren’t able to talk about it yet - he was called into a meeting.”

Catra nodded. “And Daniel’s been hiding here ever since.”

Sam and Daniel both winced at that while Entrapta looked confused. “Why would you be hiding from Jack?”

Daniel smiled. “Ah, that’s a bit complicated…”

Entrapta nodded encouragingly at him, and Catra chuckled. He wasn’t going to get out of this.

*****

“Commander, we cannot just leave this world be! Apophis lost his task force here, Heru’ur lost the planet - both will want to find out what happened!”

Bryce had a good point there, Jack O’Neill admitted. Both of the two head snakes, and probably half their rivals once they heard of it, would send scouts, spies or even probing forces to this world to find out what happened and who held it. Of course, it was a point that was pretty obvious and so had been raised during the planning phase of this operation. And had been addressed as well.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “We’re aware of that, General. And we won’t leave the system defenceless. But we don’t need to control the planet to defend it. We can leave a task force in the system to destroy invaders.”

“But that runs the risk of them detecting our presence and plans here!” Bryce objected. “That would jeopardise our entire war plans!”

“Holding the planet would not decrease that risk either - quite the contrary,” Glimmer retorted.

“But even if we lock down space, that still leaves the Stargate! And the locals cannot defend it. We have to either defend it

ourselves or remove it from the planet." Bryce wasn't giving ground there.

"Or give them the ability to prevent others from using it," Adora said. "A simple mechanism to keep it horizontal unless raised to be used would keep anyone from using it for an invasion - without having to place it in a foreign base."

A simple mechanism by Carter or Entrapta's standards, Jack mentally amended - but it was a good solution. Any invaders would be killed when they tried to step out of the gate and fell back into it. Of course, any peaceful visitors or explorers would suffer the same fate. But there was no perfect solution either way.

"That would still leave us committed to the system's defence, and without anything to show for it. It would be a pure drain of resources - resources needed for the war."

Jack wondered if Bryce was in someone's pocket. The man hadn't struck him as the type to care so much for the strategic implications of the operation that he was willing to argue with the Supreme Commander of the Alliance over it. Certainly not without backing from his own superiors. Civilian or military.

"It's going to take a task force from the fleet," Glimmer replied. "And nothing to show for it? As you said, they will be dealing with recon and probing attacks, perhaps even invasions, from the Goa'uld. Which means they'll reduce the enemies' forces."

"And draw their attention to this system, potentially weakening their control over other systems," Percival added.

"Although this will endanger this system," the German general, Müller, pointed out. "And the more forces the Goa'uld focus on it, the more of our forces will be needed to defend it. This could become a Verdun."

"No matter how many forces they send at us, we will defeat them! We cannot fail under the command of Your Divine Highness!"

Jack didn't bother to hide his grimace at Priest's outburst. The clone had kept silent so far, to jack's surprise, but it was obvious that he had overcome his shame or embarrassment for 'failing' Adora and was back to full confident fanaticism.

Adora winced. "Thank you, Priest." She nodded at the generals. "We were aware of this potential issue before we launched this mission, and there's no need to change our plans and contingencies for this. If it becomes too costly or impossible to hold the system, we'll pull out and leave the population with an underground network of tunnels to shelter and hide in and enough resources to survive for years if they do not want to evacuate through the Stargate."

"A very generous offer," Duchemin commented.

"Your Divine Highness provides for those in need."

"It's the least we can do if we fail in our duty to protect them," Glimmer said. She wasn't reacting to Priest's comment, Jack noted.

"But shouldn't we ask the people here to make an effort for their own protection as well?" Bryce asked. "Of course, we cannot expect them to provide an effective military force - they are barely out of the stone age, after all - but they could provide the war effort with the same resources that they mined for the Goa'uld. That shouldn't be too much to ask of them after we've bled for their freedom. And with modern technology and organisation, the output of their mines could surely be increased significantly."

Ah, that was his angle! Jack almost snorted as he wondered which mining corporations were ready to move in from Earth.

"Of course, we'll *ask* them if they wish to sell their ore," Glimmer told him. "But that's, ultimately, their decision. If they wish to stop mining, then we will accept that - none of the ore mined here is crucial for our war effort."

"And why do you think they couldn't help us militarily?" Adora frowned. "They can learn how to fight just as anyone else can with the right training. If they wish to join our forces, we'll happily accept them."

Bryce blinked. "But… they come from a culture on the technological level of Ancient Egypt! How are they supposed to operate tanks and modern weapons when they have grown up using horses and spears?"

Glimmer glared at him. "My royal guards use spears. And my people use horses. All of them fought well against people in tanks and spaceships."

"It doesn't take a lot to teach people how to effectively use modern weapons. Like the Soviets found out when we taught the Mujahedin how to use Stingers," Jack cut in.

Bryce glared at him, but Adora nodded. "Yes. But it will be their decision. We are not here to take over but to save and support people. We aren't the Goa'uld," she added with a frown. "We will gladly accept any help, but we will not demand it."

"A policy which was set in the Alliance Charter," Glimmer pointed out. Under her breath, she added: "We've read up on your history."

And that was it. Jack liked Bryce's expression, but he knew that the man's backers would not give up so easily. And the Europeans might be more discreet, but they would also be salivating at the thought of getting access to the resources of entire planets.

And once they realised that the Etherians actually meant what they said about leaving such decisions to the locals, Sadiki and his people would be swamped with offers from corporations and politicians with vast experience in exploiting Third World countries.

Jack didn't think they would be more successful or luckier than the countries on Earth. Not even with Daniel's help. Which was

something he still needed to discuss with his friend, he reminded himself.

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Adora kept smiling - confidently and friendly, she reminded herself, not like Glimmer baring her teeth - as they left the meeting room. She might disagree with General Bryce's opinions, but they were all on the same side here. Probably. While she had no doubt that they were all working to defeat the Goa'uld, she wasn't as sure that they all meant the same when they talked about 'winning the peace'.

"Ugh!" Glimmer said when they had turned two corners and were - presumably - out of earshot of the earth officers. Well, except for Jack, who was walking with them. "What were they thinking?"

"Is that a rhetorical question, or do you want an answer?" Jack asked with a snort.

Glimmer scoffed in return. "I know what they are thinking. It's 'Hey, those poor primitive people need our guidance. Let's take over their world for their own good! And for ours!'."

"You've studied Earth's history extensively," Jack commented.

"Please!" Glimmer snorted before Bow could say anything. "We heard it all a dozen times every day from your … pundits, I think is the name. Back when you all were panicking that we would do this to you. We couldn't have missed learning about your colonialism and neo-colonialism periods if we tried."

"Though I did study both in more detail than that," Bow added. "Since, well, Earth is, according to some people, still in the neo-colonialism era."

"Well, yeah, some people are opinionated about that," Jack replied. "But not really wrong." He sighed. "They'll try to swindle the people here, you know."

“We know,” Glimmer told him. “They’ll try to do the same thing they were afraid we’d do to them: Exploit them under the pretext of helping them.”

“We need to warn Sadiki and his people of that,” Adora added. “But, ultimately, we have to let them decide what they want.”

“Even if they mess up and ruin their world?” Jack asked.

Adora nodded. “If we try to force our own ideas on them, we’d be no better than the Goa’uld.” Or the First Ones.

“But we can offer them advice,” Bow added.

“Yes!” Priest chimed in. “We shall teach them about your deeds and your wisdom, Your Divine Highness, so they, too, might benefit from your guidance!” He bowed in the middle of the hallway and added: “After asking for their permission, of course!”

“Of course,” Adora replied, wincing. She couldn’t prohibit the clones from talking to others - well, she could, but it would make her a hypocrite. And a dictator. But she really didn’t want more people worshipping her.

“Well, you won’t be the only ones,” Jack told him. “You can bet that the missionaries from Earth will chomp at the bit to spread their faith - and they’ll demand equal opportunities.”

“As is fair,” Priest replied. He turned to smile at her. “However, unlike them, Your Divine Highness’s deeds and power are real, as anyone on this world can see when they visit the Divine Fields blessed with your divine power or when they work magic which was restored to their world by your will.”

“I’m not a goddess,” Adora told him. She wasn’t. She was She-Ra, Princess of Power. A princess like other princesses. Mostly.

Priest bowed low but didn’t agree. Which she had expected.

“You know, having a holy war on this world won’t really help anyone,” Jack said.

“If you need violence to spread your faith, you are following false gods,” Priest retorted with a serene smile. Which looked like the smiles of the clones worshipping Horde Prime. Like Catra’s when she had been… Adora pushed that painful memory away.

Jack narrowed his eyes. “Speaking of false gods, when your god tells you they’re no god, shouldn’t you listen to them?”

Adora drew a sharp breath, and she saw Glimmer and Bow tense up.

But Priest kept smiling. “Like when your god tells you to sacrifice your child?”

Jack stared at him. “That’s not the same.”

“Indeed, it is not.” He bowed towards Adora. “Your Divine Highness, you would never demand such a thing from us to test us.”

“Of course not!” Adora blurted out before she realised what she was doing.

“You lead by example. Your deeds speak for themselves, and we follow your guidance by our choice.” Priest bowed again. “Your wish is our holy command, for we place our trust in your power and your wisdom and your honesty and benevolence.”

Adora winced again.

And Jack looked annoyed.

But they had arrived at the room Catra had commandeered. And where the rest of their friends were supposed to be. So, Adora couldn’t really continue this discussion.

She opened the door. “Hello!”

“Hey, Adora!” Catra jumped up from her chair and moved towards her, hips swaying, swishing in that distracting, sexy way of hers.

“...and so, you see, I had to explain all this, so… Oh, hello, Adora. Jack.” Daniel blushed a little. “I was just, ah, explaining…”

“He was telling us why the generals were mad at him for doing the right thing.” Entrapta nodded. “It’s complicated,” she added, “but he can explain it.”

“So I’ve heard,” Jack commented with a toothy smile.

Adora was about to frown at him - Daniel had done the right thing - but Catra hugged her, and that was even more distracting than her strut.

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“So, you decided to teach the locals all about interstellar politics in an afternoon. *Everything* they need to know to make the best, most informed decisions about their future. Right, Daniel?”

The Colonel wasn’t happy with their friend. Samantha Carter could understand why he was annoyed, but that didn’t mean she agreed with him. Yes, Daniel had acted without orders - his explanation that he had merely followed the obvious logical conclusions drawn from the general goals of the mission was a paper-thin excuse. Some might, would even, argue that he had acted against orders when he had contacted the local settlement.

But this wasn’t a Stargate mission. This was an Alliance operation. And the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, as well as the rest of the Etherians, obviously approved of Daniel’s decision.

“Well, not everything. Obviously, that would have taken far too long to teach them. Even a general overview of the galactic politics was a challenge.” Daniel smiled weakly. “But I did tell them about the basic stance and aims of the Alliance, yes. And that they did not owe anyone their allegiance, much less their support or property,” he added in a firmer tone.

“And that was a good thing,” Glimmer added with a nod. “We didn’t come here to take over the planet. And it seems not everyone realised that we don’t just mean outright conquest with that policy.”

“That still leaves them at the mercy of our carpet baggers,” the Colonel retorted. “Are you planning to stay here to ensure the locals won’t sell off the mines for a handful of glass beads?”

“Well, I can’t stay - but I left them a number of examples of more equitable contracts for resource extraction agreements.” Daniel’s smile turned more than a little smug right now.

“And our brothers staying here, defending the system against all enemies, will certainly do their utmost to ensure that the people are not taken advantage of, just as Your Divine Highness wishes! By offering advice and guidance, I mean.”

Sam narrowed her eyes a little at Priest’s declaration. No matter the clone’s intentions, this didn’t sound very reassuring to her. Quite the opposite, actually.

And her friends - except for Entrapta, who happily nodded in agreement, Catra, who grinned, and, weirdly, Daniel, who nodded - seemed to share her reservations.

“Remember that the people here are free to make their own decisions, for good or ill,” Adora told him with a pained smile.

“Of course, Your Divine Highness. Anything else would be a betrayal of your ideals.” And there came the deep bow the clones seemed so fond of. Sam couldn’t help but be reminded - very uncomfortably - of the way the Goa’uld were worshipped.

The Colonel was pressing his lips together in a frown. “Well, seems that’s settled then. Let’s just hope no one will start a holy war once the other missionaries arrive.”

“They would have to be allowed through the gate first,” Catra said.

"I don't think the United Nations will refuse permission if the alien missionaries are allowed to visit already," the Colonel retorted. "Of course, if you advise the locals here not to let visitors through the gate…" He glanced at Daniel, then at Priest.

"That would set an unfair precedent," Priest replied at once. "While it is their decision, we would certainly counsel the people here against closing off their world, for it is in isolation where complacency and ignorance grow. Only in the free contest between ideas and ideals can you find true, tested guidance for your life!"

That was… surprisingly liberal for a zealot, Sam had to admit.

She wasn't surprised, though, not this time, that Daniel agreed enthusiastically. "Yes!"

"Yeah, sure. Especially if you have such contests on a world with 'divine fields' created by your 'goddess', huh?" The Colonel glared at the clone.

What did he mean? Ah, the effects of Adora's magic, Sam remembered. The clones apparently had named the fields.

Priest inclined his head with a smug smile. "Of course. The claims of false gods pale next to such proof."

Sam couldn't help thinking that the clone was not just talking about the Goa'uld here. But he wasn't wrong, she had to admit - faced with what could arguably be seen as actual miracles, especially by people who had been raised to worship the Goa'uld, any missionary from Earth would be fighting an uphill battle.

She wasn't looking forward to discovering how this would play out - here or on Earth. Not at all. No matter who 'won' in this 'contest of ideals', there would be some very unhappy zealots. And in her experience, no matter their origin, unhappy zealots were dangerous.

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The Intervention Part 5

Forward Base, Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So… did anyone find out yet why the Jaffa here thought of burying a bomb in the lake? Did anyone show them James Bond movies or Saturday morning cartoons?"

That was a very transparent attempt to change the subject by O'Neill. At least, Catra thought so. Then again, it was a bit stupid to scold Daniel for doing something everyone else thought was the right thing to do. Although O'Neill probably agreed with it as well - in principle, at least - and just didn't like that Daniel had annoyed at least some of the generals. And their backers, of course. The man was very protective of his friends - in a grouchy old-people sort of way.

"We don't know, sir." Sam, of course, replied earnestly. "I wondered if the bomb was placed in the lake, outside of the range of most scanners, so the defenders of the gate had time to withdraw while the attacker couldn't detect much less defuse the bomb in the meantime. But we now know that Heru'ur's Jaffa were willing to die if it meant taking out an important enemy."

Catra suppressed a shudder. The Jaffa had killed themselves, blowing up their staff weapons, to kill Adora by collapsing the mine onto her. And they had come far too close for Catra's comfort to actually pull that off. Adora had taken the whole weight of the tunnel's ceiling on herself, in the middle of a crowd of panicking slaves, with the entire tunnel shaking and buckling… She took a deep breath and pushed the memory away. Adora was alive. Safe. And with Catra.

"And I don't think they knew that we wouldn't pick up the bomb there since it would have been too weak to affect the gate area if it had just blown up on the ground," Entrapta added. "They wouldn't have been able to know about our scanner's power."

“Or our procedures,” Catra added.

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded.

“Are we sure of that?” O’Neill asked.

“Sir, any leak would have to have been at the highest level.”

“Yes. Like, Sam or me. Since we upgraded the scanner recently, so we’re the only ones who know the new stats.” Entrapta nodded. “And I know it wasn’t me, and I don’t think Sam would reveal anything either.”

“Of course not!”

“Perish the thought!” O’Neill grinned. “If you keep the scanner’s real power a secret even from your superiors, then I doubt you’d sell us out to the enemy.”

“Of course not, sir!”

Sam was blushing a little, Catra noted - no doubt a response to O’Neill’s slightly teasing tone. They really should admit their feelings.

“Do the prisoners we took know anything?” Adora asked.

“All of those we interrogated so far claim to have not known anything about this.” O’Neill shrugged. “It might have just been a Jaffa trying to be clever.”

“Jaffa generally are not encouraged to ‘be clever’,” Teal’c said. “In fact, such behaviour is discouraged - often harshly.”

“And it couldn’t have been an experiment,” Sam added. “Unless wrecking their own base would have been an acceptable result for a test.”

“I don’t think that would have been the case,” Entrapta said. “Unless they wanted to replace the old base.”

Catra snorted. “That would have ruined the surprise, though. If we had found traces of such flooding, we would have been on our guard.”

“Right!” Entrapta nodded emphatically.

“On the other hand,” Catra went on, “We do know that the Jaffa improvised when we took out their explosives. So, maybe Heru’ur didn’t discourage ‘being clever’?” She looked at Teal’c.

The Jaffa inclined his head. “Indeed. It might be that Her’ur’s known camaraderie with his warriors extends to trusting them with such… innovations. Using the lake to amplify the bomb’s effect was an ingenious way to avoid using more refined Naquadah, after all.”

“Great. We almost died under a tidal wave of mud because some Jaffa tried to impress his boss.” O’Neill scoffed.

“Impressing your superior through outstanding deeds during battle, on the other hand, is generally encouraged.” Teal’c tilted his head, and Catra caught his lips twisting into a hint of a smile. “This would have qualified, would it have worked.”

“Yeah, sure. Maybe we did catch the one who thought of this and just didn’t get around to interrogating them yet,” O’Neill said. “But captured or killed, it’s a good thing that this guy isn’t serving Heru’ur any more.”

Catra nodded in agreement. Clever enemies were a pain to deal with. It was much easier to defeat enemies who blindly followed orders. Or to be defeated with such troops.

At least whatever bastard had had this idea couldn’t get away. They had control of the Stargate and the orbitals. And they were tracking every Jaffa on the planet through the Naquadah in their symbionts. Soon, the last of them would be captured. Or killed - Catra really didn’t care what would happen to them as long as they were dealt with.

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Northern Hills, PZ-921, January 13th, 1999 (Earth Time)

The Jaffa had picked a good location for their last stand, Jack O'Neill had to admit that. He studied the area with his binoculars. A narrow canyon between two steep hills - he'd call them mountains if not for Carter's insistence that they were not tall enough. Hell, he might call them mountains anyway. The valley was so narrow and twisted, and the hillsides so steep, sometimes with vast overhanging parts, that bombing runs and artillery strikes would have to rely on luck to hit the ground instead of the hills. A frontal assault would mean facing staff weapons and zats at close range - Jack wouldn't give even main battle tanks good odds of surviving that kind of crossfire. And rappelling down the hillsides… Unless you could suppress the ground, anyone could shoot you from below. Yeah, Heru'ur's Jaffa knew what they were doing.

But so did the Alliance. "I almost feel bad about this," he muttered as he lowered his binoculars.

"About offering them the chance to surrender?" Teal'c asked next to him.

"What? No," Jack replied. "That's just… You should always offer your enemy the chance to surrender if you can. People who have nothing left to lose fight the hardest." Heru'ur's Jaffa had already shown that in the mine.

"Indeed. But victory in battle generally goes not to those who fight the hardest, but those who fight with the most cunning."

"Yep."

Teal'c didn't say anything, but Jack didn't have to glance over to know his friend was waiting for him to answer his original question. He sighed. "It just feels… I've been there, you know? Sort of. Facing an enemy who outnumbers and outguns you,

doing your best to outthink and outfight them, but still ending up trapped."

"In death ground, fight."

It figured that Teal'c would have read Sun Tzu. Jack snorted, then frowned."Was that from The Art of War, or did you hear that from a Jaffa teacher?"

"I quoted the book, but since this is a common piece of advice for anyone who would wage war, it will come as no surprise that I have heard this before, during my training," Teal'c replied.

"Ah." Jack nodded. "Anyway, it feels a bit like cheating since we can track every single Jaffa on the planet thanks to their symbiont. Then again, if you're not cheating in war, you're not fighting seriously." That was a lesson that Jack had taken to heart.

"There is sometimes a fine line between a cunning and a dishonourable plan."

That was Teal'c-speak for 'don't cheat with abandon', Jack knew. He shrugged in return. "We're not exactly breaking our word. And speaking of that… Are you sure that they will honour an attempt at parley?"

Teal'c tilted his head slightly to the left. "It would be very rare - almost unheard of - for any Jaffa to break a truce for parley without explicit orders from their superior."

"That's not really reassuring," Jack commented.

"I do not think it is very likely that Heru'ur would have left such orders for his warriors. Especially since they apparently assume we represent the forces of a rival Goa'uld - breaking your word in that manner when interacting with another System Lord would hurt his reputation amongst his peers and hinder any future diplomatic moves he might plan."

"That's still not too reassuring," Jack said.

“The false gods are not known for their honour.”

“Yeah.”

“But despite this, the Alliance will still make an attempt to parley.” Teal’c sounded as if he approved.

“It’s Adora.” Jack snorted. “Of course, she can probably shrug off anything they can throw at her. As long as they don’t parley in a mine or something.”

“Indeed. And She-Ra and her friends will be prepared for treachery.”

Mostly Catra, in Jack’s opinion. “I just wish we could attend. But we’re probably a bit too infamous amongst the Goa’uld. Would give the game away.” He still expected to see his face on a Goa’uld wanted poster one of these days. If they had such things in the first place, of course.

Teal’c inclined his head. “A consequence of our many deeds in the war against the false gods. But I have trust in our friends. They are honourable and skilled.”

Jack narrowed his eyes. “Do you honestly think they’ll convince those guys to surrender instead of fighting to the last?”

“If it is possible at all, then I believe they can do it.”

Jack snorted again. So, Teal’c didn’t think either that Heru’ur’s Jaffa would surrender. Of course, out of all of the other groups they had run down, they had only been able to capture those too wounded to fight on. And Jack didn’t think there would be too many of those if it came to a fight here.

Damn, he really wanted to be at that meeting. Sure, he wasn’t a magical princess who could shrug off cannon shots or teleport everyone to safety, but… he hated letting his friends risk their lives while he stayed safely behind! “Let’s hope for the best.”

"Indeed."

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Near the canyon in the Northern Hills, PZ-921, January 13th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"For the record, I think this is a bad idea."

Adora suppressed the urge to roll her eyes at Catra's comment - they were walking up to the Canyon entrance where Heru'ur's remaining Jaffa were dug in, and if anyone was watching them through binoculars, she didn't want to show such a reaction.

"You've said that before," Glimmer said next to her.

"It bears repeating. And I'll still hurt whoever came up with this outfit."

Adora glanced to her right side and caught Cata pulling at her collar. Again. Privately, she thought her lover looked very attractive in the design. Although, maybe they should have picked less 'bling', as Jack put it - the white top and skirt combo was fine and let Catra's tail swish freely back and forth, an important consideration, but all the jewellery, especially the heavy ornamental collar that reached out to cover shoulders, were apparently not very comfortable.

"We're supposed to look like Goa'uld, so suck it up." Glimmer scoffed. "You don't hear me complaining, do you?

"You already had the look; all you needed was more jewellery and a bare midriff," Catra shot back.

"What did you say?"

"I said you already had the look."

It wasn't true - Adora was the one who had been able to keep her usual clothes, the white and gold aligning perfectly with what

many Goa'uld would choose as colours. Not that she would have been able to change her outfit, anyway. But Glimmer had to change her usual clothes like Catra. Although she didn't have fur that could get caught up in all the metal links and meshes of the jewellery. And she was used to wearing elaborate clothes to make an impression. Catra was more used to making an impression with more casual clothes. Casual, but stylish and sexy clothes, Adora amended her thought with a smile, remembering the Princess Prom.

But they were now almost at the entrance of the canyon. "I think we're close enough," Adora said. "Let's wait for them to come to us." Far enough from the canyon to be outside the effective range of staff weapons.

"Or shoot at us," Catra added.

"Don't worry, I'll port us to safety before anyone can mess up your new look," Glimmer said.

"I'll use you as a human shield."

"Then I'll leave you behind."

Glimmer seemed to be a bit more nervous than she wanted to let on - Adora's friends were bickering more than usual. "Please…" Adora started to say.

"Quiet! Here they come!" Catra hissed.

Oh? Adora squinted her eyes. There was movement at the canyon. Two, no, three people emerging from the shadows.

"Jaffa. Same armour as the ones we fought," Catra commented.

"Well, who else could it be?" Glimmer asked.

"Infiltrators from Apophis?"

“None of our sources have reported that he had troops on the planet.”

“They might have missed that like they missed the tsunami bomb.”

“That was different.”

“Guys…” Adora whispered. She could now see the Jaffa clearly as they approached. They looked… a bit scruffy. The metal of their armours wasn’t polished but seemed to be covered in dust. Was that deliberate, or just the result of the Jaffa’s trip through the wilderness?

She straightened a bit and raised her chin. She had to make the right impression on the Jaffa. They were used to Goa’uld claiming to be gods and demanding worship. She wouldn’t do that, of course, but she had to project confidence if she wanted to be taken seriously.

The three Jaffa, all of them carrying staff weapons, approached until they were about ten paces away, then stopped and stared at Adora and her friends. Mostly at Catra - one of them whispered, but Adora couldn’t make out what he said.

“They think I’m a ‘Sekhmet’, whatever that is. Something related to Bastet,” Catra whispered.

Bastet? That was a System Lord, although a rather obscure one, as Adora recalled from her research on the enemy. But it was an opening.

She took a step forward. “I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. My companions are Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon, and Catra.”

The Jaffa tensed. “You are not Goa’uld,” their leader told her.

Right, the voice. Well, Adora had never planned to lie during the negotiations - the Goa’uld style was just to make them come out to parley. She shook her head. “No, we aren’t.” She waited a

moment. She didn't like doing this. But she didn't like to lie either. "I am a First One. You know them as the Ancients - the Gate Builders."

One of them, the youngest-looking, gasped. The others hissed through clenched teeth.

But their leader recovered quickly. "That is a bold claim. The Gate Builders have been gone for millions of years."

"Someone studied their history," Catra commented.

"Not all of us left," Adora said. "Some stayed. Some left this universe." That was technically correct - if you counted the pocket dimension Etheria had been sealed in by Mara. "But I have returned."

"To fight the gods?"

He still hadn't introduced himself or his companions, Adora noted. "To save the people. To free them from slavery," she replied. "We heard of a plan to massacre the people of this planet and intervened."

"Lies!" one of the younger Jaffa spat. "The Great Heru'ur would never do that to his loyal subjects!"

"It was one of his rivals," Adora told them. "Apophis, hoping to frame Sokar for the deed."

That didn't seem to surprise them, but they exchanged glances. Their leader spoke up again: "And you used the opportunity to attack while we fought them? Like a carrion eater?"

That… it wasn't like that!

"'Carrion eaters'?" Catra sneered. "We destroyed both Apophis's fleet and your paltry forces in space before they engaged each other, and we crushed you on the ground at the same time. You're all that's left of Heru'ur's forces."

“And you want us to surrender to you? Betray our god?”

Adora refrained from nodding. The Jaffa was right, but she knew better than to admit it right away. They had to be a bit more diplomatic about it if they wanted to convince the Jaffa to surrender.

“Because even if you don’t surrender, you can’t do anything for your god any more,” she said. “You cannot fight us any more. You cannot hide, either - we know exactly where you are at any time.”

She nodded Glimmer, and her friend disappeared in a shower of sparkles.

Once more, the Jaffa gasped - and even their leader looked surprised, maybe even shocked, when Glimmer reappeared a moment later with a bot in her hands.

She put it down, and a holographic projection appeared in front of it, showing the canyon - and the Jaffa inside it. All of them.

The Jaffa tensed up again, and the two younger ones glanced at each other. But their leader had regained his composure and frowned. “Every one of us is ready and willing to die in service of our god.”

“Of course,” Adora said, nodding. “But why should you die pointlessly? We have you surrounded, and we don’t need to storm the canyon - we have ships in orbit that can simply destroy the entire area. Your death here wouldn’t serve your god - or anyone else.”

“It will serve as an example to others,” their leader retorted. “Inspire them to do their utmost in service of the Great Heru’ur.”

Adora clenched her teeth. They sounded like Horde Prime’s clones. But the clones had learnt better, she reminded herself.

“To serve as an example, people have to hear about it,” Catra pointed out with a snort. “And who do you think will tell them? Do

you honestly expect us to spread the news?" She pointed at the holoprojection. "We can turn this into a crater, and no one will know. There's no settlement nearby, and the only other Jaffa on the planet are our prisoners. You won't inspire anyone - you'll simply vanish."

For a moment, Adora hoped that this would shake the Jaffa's fanatical loyalty.

But the older Jaffa shook his head with a glare. "Our god will know."

"Really?" Glimmer said. "How would he know? He didn't know about Apophis's plan, did he? Or about our attack. Why do you think he will know about your fate here?"

"When we appear in front of him in the afterlife, ready to be judged, we'll tell him."

Horde Prime sees all, Horde Prime knows all…

Adora had been afraid of this. If the Jaffa were convinced that they would meet their god in the afterlife, ready to be judged, then they wouldn't fear death. It would take more than a military defeat to shake their faith in their false god - but Heru'ur wasn't here for Adora and her friends to personally beat and expose as a fraud.

"And what will you tell him? That you had the chance to find out more about us but decided to die instead of doing your duty?" Catra asked, cocking her head and flashing her fangs at them.

"What?" They looked confused, even their leader.

"If you surrender, you become our prisoners. You will have the opportunity to observe us and our forces. Gather more information. If you die now, you won't really be able to tell your god anything useful."

"We can inform him that he is facing a Gate Builder."

“A claim you doubted yourself,” Catra retorted. “Will you tell that to your god?”

Yes. Adora smiled as she saw the older Jaffa glance at his companions. If the Jaffa surrendered, even if they did so with the plan to spy on the Alliance, then Adora and her friends could work on teaching them the truth about the Goa’uld. And keep them from killing themselves.

But then the Jaffa straightened, raising his chin, and stared at them. “I will not be deceived by such trickery. I will face my god with my honour intact, and he will judge me fairly.” He nodded, followed by the other two. “We will not surrender. This parley is over.”

Adora clenched her teeth. This was so, so… pointless! They would die for Goa’uld lies!

Glimmer, also angry - Adora could tell - nodded in return. “Then that is your decision.”

Adora wanted to scream at them, even plead for them to reconsider, see reason. This was just a senseless death. But that wouldn’t have helped. Maybe if she had the power to turn the canyon into a field of wheat or something… but she didn’t. So she nodded, curtly. “Goodbye then.”

She felt Glimmer grab her hand, and a moment later, all of them were back at their field headquarters. All except the bot - she could see the feed from its sensors on the big screen here, showing the Jaffa walking back to the canyon.

“Well, some people are just too stupid to live,” Catra commented.

Jack nodded. “Don’t blame yourself. You did all you could to make them see reason.”

Adora didn’t believe him. She didn’t quite know what else she could have done, but there had to be something. Anything. They couldn’t just kill all the Jaffa for believing Goa’uld lies.

“So… time to blow up the canyon from orbit?” Jack asked. “Or just starve them out?”

“They would not surrender either way. If they were growing too weak to fight, they’ll charge us,” Teal’c said.

“Banzai charges. Yay.” Jack scoffed.

Catra shrugged. “So, unless you found a way to take them out without killing them and risking our own soldiers’ lives in the process, it’s bombing time. At least that will be quicker than letting starve.”

But it still wasn’t right. “I’ll do it,” Adora said.

“Adora!” Catra hissed at her.

But Adora shook her head. This was her fault, so she would fix it. She would take them all down. If she couldn’t convince them with words to see reason, then she would knock some sense into them with her sword.

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Field Headquarters, PZ-921, January 13th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“I thought the whole idea was not to risk our soldiers trying to save our enemies’ lives,” the Colonel commented.

“I can deflect their staff blasts,” Adora retorted. “Or shrug them off.”

They had never specifically tested that, but Samantha Carter didn’t doubt the claim - she knew from Entratpa and the others that She-Ra had taken worse than a staff blast.

“You’re not invulnerable,” Catra snapped. “And what if the Jaffa bring down the canyon on you?”

"They would have to have more explosives than we scanned and would have to prepare for that." Adora nodded at the holoprojection displaying the data from Sam and Entrapta's scanner. "They are spreading out, not concentrating."

Changing positions, probably hoping that we have bluffed about our scanners, Sam thought.

"They could get lucky," Catra insisted.

"If the canyon comes down, I can still jump out."

Now that was… not quite a boast, but Sam would prefer to see proof of that before accepting it.

"You'd need to be lucky yourself for that," Catra insisted. But she was scowling in a way that made Sam suspect she believed Adora.

"I can't just let them kill themselves because they think the Goa'uld are gods," Adora said.

Sam half-expected the Colonel to make a quip about how she totally could but didn't want to, but he just frowned at her. And Glimmer and Bow nodded, though they didn't seem to like it, either.

"Use zats?" Daniel suggested.

"You have to get fairly close with those in the first place, and in the Canyon with all those twists and turns and rocks littering the ground, you'd be almost in melee range anyway. It's the same for our shock rods." Catra shook her head.

"If we had some way to knock them unconscious without engaging them in close combat…" Bow trailed off and pressed his lips together.

Catra turned to glare at him. "If we had that, we'd save it for a more important mission than saving a bunch of fools from their

own stupidity!"

"We could use it for both," Bow replied.

"We can't expect the enemy not to adapt to our plans and technology." Catra shook her head and turned back to glare at Adora. "But it's not just that they could get lucky, you also plan to knock them out. If you want to avoid killing or maiming them, you'll have to be far too careful to fight effectively. Especially with a shock rod or zat."

It was Adora's turn to scowl. "I have to at least try!" she shot back - but she sounded more desperate than determined.

Catra met her eyes for a moment, then blinked - and sighed. "No, *you* don't have to try. Others can do better. But we'll need the Stargate to bring them here. And we need a frigate."

"Oh?" Adora looked hopeful.

"What are you planning?" Glimmer asked.

"Something stupid and far too elaborate, so it'd be right up your alley," Catra replied. Then she started explaining.

It was the most absurd plan Sam had heard in a long time. Since her time at the Air Force Academy, actually. But she couldn't find a reason why it wouldn't work. And Entrapta agreed.

And, judging by the way he was shaking his head and muttering about 'Saturday morning cartoons', the Colonel had no good argument either.

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Near the canyon in the Northern Hills, PZ-921, January 14th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"I don't want to hear any snarky comments. The only reason I have proposed this plan is to keep you from doing something

stupid. If I had my way, we would be dropping bombs and blaster bolts on them until there's only a crater left of the entire canyon." Catra glared at Adora to emphasise her words. This was all her lover's fault. Everything. "The things I do for you…" she sighed.

In response, Adora hugged her. Which was nice. But it didn't quite make up for all the annoyances Catra had to deal with here. "I was the leader of the Horde. I directed tank divisions and fleets," she mumbled.

"Yes, you were," Adora replied. "Look, it's starting!"

Catra pulled back and looked up. In the distance - quite the distance, Catra had insisted Entrapta and Sam doubled it - a Horde frigate, Priest's flagship of the task force, actually, descended and opened up with her ventral broadside, lasers and blaster bolts striking the ground below, starting far outside the canyon range and drawing closer.

Catra hoped that the idiots in the canyon at least were scared by this. It would serve them right for making her do this. "We could have just used this on the canyon," she muttered.

Adora didn't comment as they watched the short bombardment.

"Your will has been done, Your Divine Highness!" Priest reported over the communicator as the frigate pulled up again.

"Thank you, Priest!" Adora replied cheerfully. "Entrapta?"

"One moment! The scanners need to adjust - all the power kind of disturbed the readings… ah, yes! Both the crater and the furrow match the projected data within tolerances! That means we can proceed with phase two!"

Of course, Entrapta would be excited about this. Sam and Bow were probably as enthusiastic but hid it better. Catra sighed again. "Proceed with phase two."

"Yes!"

"As the Chosen Consort of Her Divine Highness commands!"

Catra shot a frown at Adora, who steadily ignored it, then looked up again.

They didn't have to wait long. Glowing balls of not-quite-fire were quickly falling from the sky. "What a waste!" she complained as the first struck, throwing up a plume of ash quickly disturbed by the next impact. And the one after that. And the ones following them. She could feel the ground tremble slightly even at this distance. If the canyon collapsed from this… But it didn't. As the geologists they had called in for this had told them.

"The pattern of the craters adheres to our projections. Mostly. Some corrections are necessary. Transmitting data to you, Priest!"

"Thank you! Commence firing when ready!"

Shortly afterwards, the frigate reappeared in the sky and started firing her ventral guns into the smoke and dust concealing the impact area.

"Take care to melt the bits that are still solid!"

"Of course!"

Priest was enjoying this as much as Entrapta was, Catra realised. Of course, he was doing his goddess's work, so to speak, so she should have expected that. And he was probably already thinking of how to use this to convert the idiots in the canyon.

Well, that wasn't her problem.

"Mission accomplished!"

"The furrow is starting to fill!"

Adora was beaming.

Cara sighed again and pushed the button of her communicator. "Mermista, Frosta, you're up."

"Yes!"

"Finally!"

"This shall be a day to be remembered, my love!"

"Ugh, don't distract me!"

Catra shook her head and picked up her binoculars. She didn't want to miss the conclusion of this.

*****

In a way, it was a fitting end to the campaign, Jack O'Neill was forced to admit as he watched the canyon through his own binoculars. Sure, Carter and Entrapta's sensors offered a detailed overview, but some things you had to see with your own eyes. And this hare-brained operation certainly qualified.

"All the ice has melted - or evaporated, but the losses are within expected tolerances," Carter reported. "The water's flowing into the furrow."

It was more like a canal, in Jack's opinion. Wide enough to let a few yachts pass. Sizeable ones, too. Of course, they wouldn't survive it right now - not with the current becoming a flash flood that would wreck even large boats as if they were toys.

Jack clenched his teeth as he remembered the tidal wave that had almost drowned them in the enemy base. This was different, he reminded himself. It wasn't nearly as powerful, for starters. And it was under control.

He still shuddered when he saw the water crest the edges of the new canal, foam covering the banks as the wave raced towards the canyon.

“The Jaffa in the canyon noticed the wave,” he heard Catra comment from behind him. She was inside the headquarters, watching the holoprojection. “Look at them run.”

“Some of the Jaffa are trying to climb the walls, Mermista!” Adora sounded concerned.

“That won’t help them!” he heard the water princess’s gleeful reply through his communicator.

“I meant, watch out so you don’t accidentally kill them!” Adora retorted.

“Don’t worry! I have it under control. Water is my element!”

“And beauty and grace!” the smuggler added.

Han Solo would have never said anything sappy like that. This really was more like a Saturday morning cartoon.

A deadly one, though, Jack amended his thought when he saw the water reach the end of the channel, close to the entrance of the canyon. There, walls made of ice appeared, catching the water and funnelling it towards the canyon like a huge… Jack couldn’t actually think of a fitting word when he saw the water reach the canyon.

Now, against all laws of nature, the water slowed down. Instead of smashing into and through the canyon like a tsunami, crushing everything inside, killing the Jaffa by battering them against the stone walls before they could drown, it almost gently filled the valley.

It was still a force of nature, though - and even slowed down by magic, it still hit the Jaffa wherever they tried to hide and brace themselves, dragging them along. Still… They were literally using water to flush out the last enemies. Like in a goddamn cartoon.

“Oh, look at them go!” Catra chuckled.

"That must have hurt!" Adora added.

"Don't worry, I have it under control!"

"We know, Mermista!"

"There's one almost at the top of the canyon!"

"Don't worry - I've got him!"

Jack turned around and stepped inside the field headquarters to check the holoprojection. He just caught one Jaffa almost at the top of the canyon's walls suddenly freezing. Literally.

"Got him!" Frosta cheered over the communicator.

Jack pressed his lips together. The princess was a kid - a teenager. Barely old enough to drive, if at all. She shouldn't be here, on an alien planet, fighting a war against genocidal maniacs.

But she had already fought in such a war. And Jack knew very well what the response would be if he mentioned his opinion. As a princess, she was expected to fight. Noblesse oblige, Daniel called it. Jack called it using child soldiers. And to think that the Etherians didn't see anything wrong with it…

"Look, they've reached the end of the canyon!"

Right. On the projection, Jack saw the water spread out as it left the canyon, carrying the tiny figures representing the Jaffa with it.

"Watch this!" Frosta exclaimed.

"Yeah, yeah."

And the figures started to freeze, like the climbing champion before. Soon the few dozen Jaffa were caught in ice, ready to be taken in. They would be freezing, probably suffering frost burn, but they were alive. And Adora could heal any wounds they suffered, anyway.

If not for the sheer absurdity of it, it would have been an almost anticlimactic ending of the operation, Jack thought as he saw the others cheer. Well, mostly the Etherians and the Junior officers in the headquarters. Percival nodded in his reserved way, the German general was openly gaping, and Bryce… looked as if he really wanted to drink himself into a stupor.

Jack grinned. There was nothing better to help cope with magical solutions than watching other people freak out at seeing it for the first time. Time to play the old hand at magic.

He stepped over to the radio and ordered the capture teams in.

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Forward Base, Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 14th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Ah, there is their idiot leader! Let's go rub it in how we destroyed them!"

"Catra!" Adora frowned at her lover. "We're not going to 'rub it in' or anything like that!" They were better than that! "We're going to check if they're OK or need healing."

"Bah! We've had to go to great lengths to take them alive, and it was all my work! Gloating about it is the least I deserve!"

Adora shook her head. "Technically, it was Mermista and Frosta's work."

"They wouldn't even be here if not for my plan." Catra scoffed. "Not that they'd thank me for letting them show off."

Uh. Adora suppressed a wince. She didn't know how serious Catra's complaint was - her lover sometimes tried to hide concerns about her relationship with the other princesses in the Alliance, out of guilt or shame - but it was a touchy subject. Better to change it. "Anyway, Mermista and Frosta did their best, but many

Jaffa still got hurt, so we have a duty to check on them and treat their wounds if necessary."

"Sure, sure." Catra grinned. "And it's a great way to convert them."

Adora narrowed her eyes at her - Catra knew what she thought about being worshipped - but before she could say anything, her lover went on: "I mean, convert to our cause, of course."

"Ah." Adora nodded. That was better.

But then Catra's grin widened, showing her fangs. "And I am sure that Priest has already plans to convert them to worshipping you."

This time, Adora did wince. She knew Priest was planning that - she had heard him talk about the captured Jaffa being marked by her, chosen to live where other enemies died. Yes, he wanted to convert them. And healing them would only make that worse.

But it was still the right thing to do. She straightened, lifting her chin, as they approached the fenced-in area where the prisoners were temporarily housed before they could be moved to a more secure - and more remote - planet without a Stargate which would serve as a central prison camp.

"And now let's hope they are still too shaken to compound their stupidity and attack us," Catra muttered. Adora didn't have to glance at her to know she was checking that the guards were attentive and ready to intervene.

Which was common sense, of course - the prisoners hadn't actually surrendered and so weren't honour-bound to behave. At least in theory; Adora knew that Catra had her doubts about how much trust could be put into that; she hadn't been shy about sharing them. But for now, the Jaffa seemed to be behaving.

The American guards at the gate in the chainlink fence topped with razorwire - NATO-style - saluted them but quickly turned their attention back to the prisoners, who had also noticed them.

They weren't gathering at the gate, but Adora could see all of them staring at her.

Well, she had weathered worse. She smiled gently as the gate was opened, and they stepped inside.

"If they try something, don't hesitate - just crush them," Catra whispered next to her. "They had their chance."

Adora nodded. As if she would risk her love getting hurt. She could summon her sword with a thought if she needed it.

Their leader - Anok; they had gotten his name while the prisoners had been processed - rose from where he had apparently been meditating. "She-Ra, Princess of Power. Catra." He bowed. Not quite as deep as Priest loved to bow, but it was more respectful than Adora had expected.

"Anok." Adora nodded at him. "How are you? Do you require healing?"

He stood ramrod straight. "I do not."

She could see that he had several bandages on his limbs, like most of the prisoners - the result of being scraped along rocks by the water - and thought about healing everyone anyway. But that would be… rude, probably. Or something. "If you do, please call me. Every prisoner has the right to medical aid."

He inclined his head very slightly, like Teal'c sometimes did, and Adora was sure he wasn't planning to ask for help. Too proud, probably.

She suppressed a sigh. They were talking, and he wasn't cursing her or her friends or trying to attack them. And the other prisoners didn't look hostile either. Things were going better than she had feared, she reminded herself.

"Still doubting our claims?" Catra asked with a smirk.

Adora pressed her lips together. They had talked about this! And just when she had thought that things were going well!

But Akon tilted his head and looked at Adora. "I stand corrected. The way you have captured us all… Whether you are a Gate Builder or not, you have demonstrated that you are a goddess."

Adora blinked, and Catra chuckled next to her. That was… Well, it made sense for someone who thought the Goa'uld were gods, but it was still wrong!

"I am no goddess," she corrected him.

He nodded in return. "As you say." His expression was… far too close to the one Priest often had on his face when talking to her, she realised.

"You've heard the clones talk during transport," Catra said.

"As you told us, we kept our eyes and ears open to gather information in captivity." Anok managed to sound both smug and respectful at the same time as he bowed his head once more.

Adora clenched her teeth. She hadn't meant it like that!

Catra was chuckling again. Louder this time.

Adora had been wrong. Things weren't going better than she had feared. Not at all.

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The Intervention Part 6

Forward Base, Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 14th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and now they think I am a goddess! And some think that's funny!"

Samantha Carter knew who Adora was complaining about - Catra hadn't even tried to hide her amusement. Sam didn't share it, though. Religious matters tended to be complicated and troublesome. And converts were often the most zealous and, therefore, the ones presenting the greatest potential problem.

"It is funny," Catra insisted. "Especially since they think you controlled the water and ice."

"Ugh. All that work, and I don't get credit?" Mermista complained.

"We have to set the record straight!" Frosta agreed.

"You just want to be also worshipped as goddesses," Catra told them with a snort.

"I already worship you, my love!"

"Ugh, not like that."

"However you want, my dear Mermista!"

Sam suppressed a frown. Mermista and Sea Hawk were… they were a couple, that much was obvious, but the way they acted together had Sam wondering how stable their relationship was. The last time she had seen that kind of dynamic had been in high school. And both Mermista and Sea Hawk were in their twenties. Of course, she wasn't exactly an expert on relationships. Or romance. Not even second-hand. And they weren't American, or even from Earth, so they would have different customs, but neither Adora and Catra nor Glimmer and Bow acted like that. Nor

did Entrapta and Hordak, but Sam did her best to ignore that relationship.

"Well, if we could tone down the RomCom dialogue a little?" the Colonel spoke up. He sounded annoyed, Sam noted. More than she had expected. "We do have a few dozen prisoners to deal with. Prisoners, I'll note, who might think they could suicide to pass on intel to their leader."

Adora winced at that. "Sorry."

"It's not our fault," Catra said with a scowl. "They came up with that themselves. Before we even talked to them."

"However it happened, we have to deal with this," General Percival said. "We cannot let our prisoners kill themselves - we have a duty towards their welfare."

"If they want to kill themselves, that's their business," General Bryce disagreed. "Some even think that's their right." He shrugged. "Let them kill themselves if they want to."

"That's incredibly callous! You cannot compare this to an informed decision to commit suicide - they honestly think they will meet their god in the afterlife!" Daniel blurted out. "We can't let them kill themselves over such a lie!"

"Indeed." Teal'c nodded.

"Are we going to restrict their freedom of religion?" Bryce asked.

Sam couldn't tell if the general was actually serious, but she was surprised to see Daniel blink and hesitate. "It's not like that," Daniel said after a moment. "We *know* that the Goa'uld lie to their slaves about being gods. This is more… like a scam."

"Well, it's not the first religion that is actually a scam," the Colonel said.

Daniel tilted his head slightly to the side. “Actually, the Goa’uld might be the first such scam - at least the first we know about. It’s certainly the biggest.”

Sam had to smile at that - and at the Colonel’s expression.

“Of course, that depends on how you see the various religions on Earth,” General Soissant pointed out. “But I think we have a less theological and more practical problem to solve since even if the prisoners would convert, it’s unlikely that they would do so very quickly, so the threat of at least some of them killing themselves remains. That wasn’t anticipated in planning, so I fear our procedures will be insufficient.”

Sam made a mental note to address this in the debriefing.

“We can keep them under guard and intervene when we notice an attempt at suicide,” General Müller suggested. “That’s standard practice, anyway.”

“You would not be quick enough to stop a Jaffa from killing another at their request,” Teal’c told him. “You would have to isolate all of them, and even then, there are ways to kill oneself quickly, almost instantly, if one is determined and skilled enough.”

Which Jaffa generally were.

“Scheisse!” the German cursed under his breath. “That would violate their rights as well. Isolation is torture,” he added.

“Isolating prisoners is justified if it’s necessary to save their lives,” General Percival objected. “If they are endangered by the other prisoners, for example. Which would be the case here.”

“They’d still suffer, though,” Glimmer pointed out.

“But they’d live.” General Bryce rolled his eyes. “We can only do so much.”

It was clear that the Etherians disagreed, but they didn't seem to have better ideas on how to handle this. Sam couldn't help them, either. She might be able to rig up bots to surveil the prisoners and intervene if needed, but that wouldn't prevent a trained Jaffa from killing someone else with one blow. Even in handcuffs. And if they were put in restraints around the clock…

"We need to talk to them as soon as possible," Daniel said. "And we need to make them see that the Goa'uld are false gods."

He was correct, of course - but Sam didn't know how they could do this. Not quickly and efficiently enough to avoid hurting the prisoners one way or the other.

On the other hand, while the Etherians and Daniel clearly hated it, sometimes, there was no easy or simple solution to a problem. Especially in a war.

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Should they let the prisoners kill themselves or keep them alive, even if that meant treating them cruelly? Catra didn't know what would be worse. They are enemies, she told herself, and if they want to die, we can oblige them - it's not our fault. But it rang hollow. The Jaffa had been raised to blindly follow their leaders - worship them as gods, even. They didn't know any better. Couldn't know any better.

Catra knew how that worked. Sure, she had seen through the Horde propaganda, even as a cadet, but she hadn't really realised that there were better ways to live. To fight. Alternatives that were available in the Princess Alliance. And when she had realised that, she had been too angry, too proud, too stupid to take them. So much pain and hurt, just because she hadn't been smart and strong enough…

She pressed her lips together and forced herself to focus on the problem at hand. This was an opportunity to change things. For the better. "It's not going to be easy to convince them that they

were lied to and manipulated their whole life," she said. Oh, how she knew how that felt! Shadow Weaver had been a master of manipulation, playing her like a fiddle. Her and Adora. "And it's not going to be quick."

"We know that," Glimmer said. "That's why we're looking for more effective solutions."

"Yeah." Catra took a deep breath. "I have an idea, but you're going to hate it." This wasn't going to be pretty.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes at her. As did O'Neill, who muttered something about already having hated her plan to capture them.

Catra ignored both and looked at her lover. Adora would hate it. But Adora would hate it even more if those idiots killed themselves after they had gone to all that effort to take them alive. "You're going to have to put the fear of god into them."

"What?" Adora blinked.

"What do you mean?" the American general asked.

"Or, to be more precise, the fear of goddess," Catra went on. "If you make them think that even in death, they can't join their god, then they will have fewer reasons to kill themselves."

"You want me to make them think I'm a goddess!" Adora blurted out. "You want me to lie to them!"

"Yes." Catra nodded. "As long as it keeps them alive long enough to make them see the truth."

"But…" Adora pressed her lips together in that pouting way she used when she didn't know what to say. "It would be based on a lie. I'd *manipulate* them," she added with a scowl.

Like Shadow Weaver. Catra suppressed a wince and slowly nodded. "If it keeps them from killing themselves? And they already think you're a goddess - even after you denied it to their

face." If the enemy was making a mistake, you were supposed to exploit it, after all.

Adora clenched her teeth - Catra could see her jaw muscles twitch.

"Converting them would facilitate turning them to our side," Soissant cut in.

"We wouldn't be any better than the Goa'uld if we did that," Adora said, glaring at him. "We cannot earn their trust by lying to them. Honesty is the best policy."

Oh for… Catra frowned at the idiot. "You don't have to lie. It's true that when they die, they won't meet their god since he's a fraud."

"They won't believe that," O'Neill said. "That's the problem."

"They believe that you're a goddess, though. So, you've got better credibility," Catra pointed out to her lover.

"But in their religion, the Goa'uld struggle with each other and resort to lies and trickery," Daniel said. "They would expect a rival goddess to lie to them to make them convert."

Catra shrugged again. "It's worth a try. It can't hurt, anyway, can it?"

"It still feels wrong to let them think I am goddess," Adora complained.

"And it would make converting them to a real religion harder," the American General, Bryce, pointed out.

That was… Catra narrowed her eyes. "A *real* religion?"

"One that isn't a scam with false gods," Bryce replied.

"But how do you prove that a god isn't false?" Bow asked.

Bryce frowned at him but took a moment to answer: "We're talking about the Goa'uld here. They claim to be gods, which is provably false." He looked at Adora. "And it's also true that you're no goddess."

"Of course not!" Adora nodded emphatically.

"That actually depends on your definition of godhood," Daniel said. He looked a bit taken aback when he realised that everyone was staring at him - especially Adora. But he rallied quickly. "I mean, many so-called pagan religions have deities who aren't, in myth and lore, omnipotent like the Abrahamic god. Just very powerful. She-Ra would fit those definitions."

Adora blinked, and Catra had to suppress a chuckle at her expression. This particular point had been brought up before, but Adora seemed determined to ignore it.

"You could honestly claim to be a demi-goddess of old?" Daniel suggested. His tentative smile faded away at Adora's scowl, though.

"I don't want to be worshipped!" Adora insisted.

"You could get a TV show instead?" Jack grinned. "Warrior Princess She-Ra? There's good money in that."

"An how would you know about that, Jack?" Daniel asked.

"I've got a TV and I need to watch something when there's no Hockey on."

"Sure, sure."

"I'm not sure we should push ancient religions on other civilisations," Sam pointed out. "We might end up playing into the hands of Goa'uld who have taken up the mantle of Greek gods."

"We're not going to push any religion on them," Adora said, still scowling.

“Does that mean you’ll prohibit your followers from proselytising?” Bryce asked.

“That might infringe their freedom of religion,” Daniel added before Adora could answer.

“I am aware of that. Which is why I won’t do it,” she told them. “But I don’t want to be worshipped as a goddess!”

It sounded a bit whiny instead of firm. Catra was sure Adora would end up doing something like what they were discussing. Eventually.

*****

Jack O’Neill generally didn’t like rushing into things. Not when things were serious, at least. Sure, he was good at thinking on his feet, and flying by the seats of your pants and succeeding was an incredible feeling - he was honest enough to admit both - but only if you actually succeeded. And even then, odds were a rush job wasn’t as efficient as a well-planned action, and in a war, efficiency was often measured in lives. Yours and the enemies’.

The enemies’, in this case, Jack thought when he approached the temporary prison camp with his Daniel and the Etherians. If they failed at this, many Jaffa would kill themselves. And while Jack usually didn’t care too much about the enemy, it was a fact that the Jaffa were - most of them, at least - fighting for the Goa’uld because they were indoctrinated from birth and didn’t know any better.

But that didn’t make them innocent. “Don’t forget that all of them have blood on their hands - innocent blood,” he commented. The snakes used their Jaffa not only to fight their rivals but also to oppress their slaves. “And they never questioned their ‘god’.” Unlike Teal’c. Who should be here but wasn’t since his presence might enrage the prisoners or something.

He noticed Catra tensing up and clenched his teeth. She had blood on her hands as well. Jack knew more than enough by now,

just based on what he heard when talking with the Etherians, to be sure. She had switched sides, like Teal'c, though she obviously still felt guilty about it. Which made Jack wonder how Teal'c felt about his time as Apophis's First Prime.

"Questioning your god isn't exactly encouraged in many religions," Daniel pointed out. "Not to the degree that would qualify as critical thinking in the modern sense. That your god was real was generally considered beyond doubt. So, I don't think we can hold that against them. Many religious texts also contain atrocities that are portrayed as good and moral."

"I'm aware of that," Jack told him.

"Most but not all religions." Priest smiled serenely, then bowed his head towards Adora. "As you taught us, you should never blindly follow anyone, Your Divine Highness. We follow you not out of blind faith, but conviction born from observation."

That was a load of bull, in Jack's opinion. The clone had all the markings of a zealot, and zealots were all about 'don't question or insult my religion, or else!'. He really would have preferred it if the fanatic wasn't with them, but the others thought it was better to introduce Priest to the prisoners while Adora was present to rein him in if needed. Or, as Jack suspected was the case with that bastard Bryce, thought the plan would work better with someone eager to convert them tagging along since Adora might not be fully behind it.

But they had reached the gates. Time to put up a unified front, Jack thought as he saluted the guards there - Military Police from the Army. All of them would have been briefed about the Jaffa's capabilities, but Jack knew from experience at Stargate Command that new recruits always underestimated the enemy. He would usually let Teal'c show them up close how dangerous Jaffa could be, but that didn't work on the scale of entire divisions being sent to land on alien planets.

“She-Ra, Princess of Power,” Akon greeted them inside the camp. He bowed to her before addressing the others. “Catra. Queen Glimmer.” Nods for them. “Colonel O’Neill.” Another nod. He didn’t stare at Priest, but the prisoners had met the clones before, when they were shuttled to the camp, so Priest would not stand out.

“I see my reputation precedes me,” Jack replied before he could help himself.

“Yes.” Akon inclined his head. “So, the Tau’ri have allied with rival gods. Or were you working for them the whole time?”

“It’s a recent thing,” Jack said. “You know, with Goa’uld being enemies of all we believe in and stuff, it just seemed the obvious thing to do.” He shrugged with a grin.

“We’re allies - they aren’t our subordinates,” Adora said with a frown.

Jack nodded. This wasn’t the time to disagree about that, even though she was glossing over the power imbalance.

“Akon, these are Daniel Jackson. Princess Frosta, Princess Mermista and… Priest,” Adora introduced the others.

Daniel smiled at them, Frosta waved with a cocky smirk, and Mermista nodded with an almost bored expression.

“Greetings, Akon of Heru’ur.” Priest bowed.

“We’ve heard about your kind,” Akon told him. “There were rumours of an upheaval in your realm.”

Jack made a mental note. That was good intel. They had known that the Goa’uld knew about Horde Prime, but this confirmed that they kept tabs on the maniac’s territory.

“Yes.” Priest nodded, his smile never changing. “Horde Prime attacked Our Divine Highness and was struck down by her in

return, freeing us from his tyranny. We've been following her since that day, guided by her wisdom."

That set the other Jaffa whispering. Jack would have to ask Catra later about what they were saying.

Akon, though, tuned to face Adora. "You have not struck down Heru'ur."

"I have not even met him yet," Adora told him.

"And yet, you wish to replace him."

"No!" Adora shook her head. "I do not wish to replace him - I wish to free his slaves so they can make their own decisions. All his slaves."

"Power shouldn't be desired for power's sake, but only as a means to do good," Priest chimed in.

Adora slowly nodded, so that was probably a direct quote of hers or she would have agreed more enthusiastically. She also looked a bit… embarrassed?

Akon glanced at Priest, then looked at Adora again. He didn't say anything, but he lifted his eyebrows.

Adora flushed, definitely embarrassed now, and Jack thought, once again, that letting Priest tag along had been a mistake.

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It wasn't like that! Not at all! The Jaffa were getting it all wrong! Adora had to correct Akon's… well, he hadn't said it, so it wasn't a claim, though he had implied it. But when she opened her mouth to tell him, she felt Catra's claws lightly pricking her thigh. Oh.

She took a deep breath and stared at Akon. "You respect Heru'ur because he fights at your side."

Akon nodded without saying anything - though he seemed to look a bit wary now.

"That is called leading by example," Adora went on. Horde cadet training had taught her that, though it had been a bit of a mixed bag in practice. "I help people. I don't expect to be obeyed or worshipped for it. I don't *want* to be worshipped. I am not looking for followers. I just want to do what's right. And lying to people to make them obey you isn't right. Nor is enslaving them."

"Loyalty is a privilege, not a right." Priest nodded again.

At least he hadn't said obedience. Not that he was particularly obedient, anyway. Well, he sort of was, but in an annoying way.

"Our god has earned our loyalty," Akon retorted.

"Has he?" Catra asked. "What did he do for you to earn your loyalty? He fights at your side, you said? But why do you fight? To protect yourself and your family, or because he orders you to fight?" She cocked her head with a snort.

Akon raised his chin, jaw set. "He guides us and will judge us after death, rewarding or punishing us as we deserve in the afterlife."

"He says he does that. But can he prove it? Promising a reward you don't plan on ever paying out is the oldest scam in the world," Catra told him. "And he doesn't even have to prove he has your reward since you're supposed to get it in the afterlife, so you can't check beforehand." She scoffed. "That's the perfect scam."

Daniel and Jack looked a bit weird, Adora noticed, but she focused on Akon.

The Jaffa shook his head. "Our god provides for us. He bestows his gifts on us in return for our loyalty."

"What gifts?" Glimmer spoke up. "Healing, food and weapons? That's just supplying your army. That's not a gift, that's part of

your *pay*."

Akon narrowed his eye at her. "It is not merely payment, but a sacred exchange. His divine power provides for us, and we repay it with our service."

"And there lies the difference," Priest nodded. "Our Divine Highness offers her help freely, yet we do not depend on her generosity. We meet our own material needs. And when she does help us, it is without any expectation of a reward. It is not an exchange, but truly a gift." He smiled, though a little sadly. "Ask anyone who served under Horde Prime, the false god, and they will tell you the same. As she said: It is by their deeds, not their promises, that you shall know people."

Adora was pretty sure she had never said that. But… that didn't make it wrong, did it? You should judge people according to what they did, not what they claimed. So she nodded. "Yes. I don't fight to make people obey and follow me - I fight to free them. To let them make their own decisions, to control their own lives. Humans and Jaffa," she added.

"And yet you do attempt to sway us from our chosen path." Akon narrowed his eyes at her.

"Because you were lied to and manipulated!" she said, a bit more forcefully than she had planned. "You need to know the truth to make your own decision."

"Yes. A decision based on lies is no decision at all, but just the illusion of one - another lie, in other words," Priest added.

"And yet, for all your claims that our god is lying to us, you have no proof at all." Akon shook his head. "Why should we believe you?"

"Ugh!" Mermista rolled her eyes. "That's not how it works. If you demand payment for something, *you* need to prove your claim. That's basic contract law."

“Our loyalty to our god is not a contract!” Akon spat. “Do not profane our faith like that!”

“It’s based on a lie!” Adora blurted out. “He’s no god! He is using technology to fool you - technology that he didn’t even invent himself but copied from others!”

“So you claim.” Akon sneered. “I await your proof.”

That was… Did she have to drag Heru’ur here and beat the truth out of him? No, that wouldn’t work. For several reasons.

Priest took a step forward. He was smiling, Adora noted. “Have you seen the Divine Fields? They are proof of her power. Where once was just devastation, irradiated mud and silt covering, poisoning the land, now fertile fields cover the ground as far as you can see. Magic was restored to the planet as well, rightening a wrong that was done a thousand years ago. Have you asked the people saved from certain death in the mines? The people healed of the ailments stemming from years of abuse?” He turned to look at her. “Look upon Her Divine Highness! Observe her deeds! She could have killed you all, yet she decided to spare you. To save you. There is your proof! Open your eyes, and look at it! And look at yourself, and your beliefs, and you will be able to tell truth from lie.” Priest bowed to Adora, then nodded at the assembled Jaffa.

Adora tried not to blush while she nodded. This wasn’t how she would have put it, but she couldn’t think of anything else to add.

Akon shook his head. “Your words won’t sway us! We are loyal!”

The Jaffa around them nodded, but… Adora thought that they looked a bit doubtful. Some of them, at least.

It wasn’t much, but it was something.

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Forward Base, Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 14th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...so, it doesn't look like we had any success. They're just too indoctrinated - they refuse to see the truth." Adora shook her head while she paced in front of the big screen in the headquarters, blocking Samantha Carter's view of the drone feed.

"People generally don't change religion so quickly or easily," Daniel pointed out. "We can't expect Jaffa to just take our word on Heru'ur being a false god. Deprogramming them, so to speak, will take time."

Sam checked that no one could see her screen and then connected her laptop to the drone feed. She was a physicist, not a sociologist - there wasn't much she could add to this debate.

"The entire point of our plan was to make them change their views quickly, before they start killing themselves to report to their god in the afterlife," Catra retorted. "So, in that, it was a failure."

"My failure, you mean." Adora sighed. "I was supposed to convince them, and I failed."

"It was my plan, my failure," Catra objected.

Sam checked the progress on the gate site while the two tried to claim the blame for their supposed failure. Entrapta and Sam had improved on the original Etherian design by having the gate be effectively buried in the ground while not in use. It was a bit more complicated than simply lowering it to the ground and back up again, but nothing too advanced. Well, handling the gate would be a problem for a pre-industrialised society, but, in theory, a team of draft animals could replace the machines they had designed for the purpose, though they would need very strong ropes to pull it off.

She almost snorted at her unintentional pun - the Colonel would have loved pointing it out to her.

Daniel, ever the optimist, still tried to put a good spin on their visit. "We did seed some doubts amongst at least a few of the Jaffa. Or that was my impression - I am no expert, of course, but

Jaffa aren't that different from humans. So, we might see dissenters amongst the prisoners in the future." He blinked. "Oh. We probably should be prepared for violence once the first Jaffa start voicing doubts about the divinity or honour of Heru'ur."

"Indeed." Teal'c nodded. "Those still blinded by their false god's lies will consider such doubts treason and react accordingly."

Which meant violently.

"Well, we're already preparing to keep them from killing themselves or each other to snitch to their god, so it shouldn't be hard to cover normal murder as well." The Colonel shrugged. "It's just a different motive, same result."

Adora sat down, sighing again, Sam noticed. "I should have done more to convince them. I could have healed them all, but…"

"...that might have killed their symbionts," Bow pointed out with a wince. "We still don't know how your healing will react to symbionts."

"And the Jaffa are used to the false gods providing healing, although not on that scale," Teal'c added. "I doubt that it would have noticeably improved your credibility amongst them since they already consider you a goddess."

Or at least claimed they did. Sam wasn't quite convinced that the Jaffa really believed that Adora was a goddess. They might just be playing along. But she wasn't an expert on Jaffa society, much less their religion. Or any religion. But, speaking of symbionts… "We also need to prepare in case any of the prisoners' symbionts are about to mature," she said. "That will either leave the symbiont in control of the Jaffa's body or, if we extract it, leave the Jaffa without a working immune system." Which was a death sentence unless the symbiont could be replaced. Even placing the subject in a sterile environment would only offer a temporary solution.

“Indeed.” Teal’c calmly nodded, his expression not showing any indication that he, too, had this fate hanging over him, although he had a few years left before it would become urgent in his case.

“Yeah. If the snakes start hatching, it will get messy.” The Colonel nodded.

“Oh, no!” Adora looked aghast. “We need to find a way to replace their symbionts - with something else, I mean. Not with another symbiont.”

“We could build an artificial immune system?” Entrapta suggested. “Or… The First Ones were great at genetic engineering. Alpha’s data might contain something helpful. Maybe we could create a species that could replace a symbiont without being a symbiont.” She perked up. “One that could provide its benefits to anyone! If we make it dumb, so it can’t take over anyone, that would be OK, right?” She beamed at the others.

Sam suppressed a wince. In theory, creating a species that wasn’t sapient - nor sentient, ideally - would be ethically acceptable. But the ramifications of such an action… Even leaving aside the expected protests against ‘playing god’ from the religious conservatives, and the fear-mongering about parasites and genetic engineering in general from the usual suspects, such a symbiont would increase the human lifespan significantly, and the effects of that on society…

Sam wasn’t a sociologist, but she didn’t need to be one to see the problems that could cause. Especially if it was too expensive to be offered to everyone.

But the Etherians were nodding in obvious agreement with Entrapta.

Sam sighed. Of course, they wouldn’t consider that. She’d have to explain.

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"...and so releasing such a symbiont to the public would need to be handled very carefully to avoid widespread unrest."

Catra blinked when Sam finished her explanation. Earth was so weird - whenever she thought she had a handle on the planet, something else popped up that made her wonder what was wrong with that planet. On the other hand, she should have expected this particular problem after the whole healing issue.

Entrapta, though, looked confused. "But… it's going to benefit everyone! People would be healthier! Live longer and better!"

Catra sighed. "But not everyone would get it right away, and that will cause problems."

"Riots," Bow said, looking grim.

"Seriously?" Mermista shook her head. "Just make it go to those who are so sick, they need it the most."

The princess didn't have any experience with Earth, Catra reminded herself.

"There are too many who need a symbiont," Adora said. "Earth has eight billion people."

"And most of them aren't good at sharing," Catra added with a snort.

"Well… there are historical reasons for that. Resources on Earth have always been distributed rather unfairly," Daniel said. "Even in the most, ah, advanced countries."

"How so?" Mermista frowned. "Don't you have that democracy system where the majority of the people decide what you do?"

"That's not a guarantee that resources are distributed fairly," Daniel told her. "And it's currently limited to individual countries - Earth doesn't have a global democratic government. So, if a country, say, offers universal healthcare to its citizens - and

residents - that only covers that country. Historically, many countries waged war over resources, and while that has fallen out of use and has been condemned as a practice by the United Nations for decades, it has not stopped less violent forms of exploitation."

"Yeah, yeah," O'Neill cut in. "Things aren't all sunshine and rainbows on Earth. But we're working on improving the situation. It just takes time, and the whole war with half the galaxy thing isn't helping."

"The United States is one of the richest countries on Earth and still has no universal healthcare," Daniel retorted. "And we've had decades of peace to work on that. It's not that easy to change the mind of people," he added. "It took official contact with aliens, I mean, Etheria, something unprecedented in history, and the threat of being left behind by other countries to push through more progressive laws in the United States in record time - which still took months."

Mermista gaped at him. Catra wished she could take a picture of the princess.

"They don't like change - any change," Glimmer said, rolling her eyes at Mermista.

"That's the conservatives," Daniel objected. "The progressives wish for faster change, but in our - the United States' - political system, any change is often slow, the result of changes in society and political compromises."

"We also have seen a lot of examples of what can go wrong when the local supreme leader makes hasty or stupid decisions," O'Neill added. "And the whole 'everyone gets the same resources' plan didn't really work out well for the communists, so everyone involved abandoned it for capitalism as soon as they were free to do so."

“But there are many different ways of building a capitalist society. The Nordic model, for example, is drastically different compared to the United States model,” Daniel said.

“What’s the Nordic model?” Frosta asked.

“The political and economic system of the Nordic countries - Denmark, Finland, Iceland, Norway, and Sweden,” Daniel explained.

“Are they located in the North?”

Catra rolled her eyes. “They’re not like your kingdom,” she told Frosta. “And we were talking about new symbionts that don’t take over your body while still providing the benefits.” She scoffed. “We can discuss the absurdity of Earth politics later.”

“And, so far, those symbionts are just a project.” Sam nodded at Entrapta. “We can worry about how to introduce them to Earth once we actually have them finished - and the Jaffa would get them first, anyway, since they depend on symbionts for their immune system.”

“Yes!” Entrapta smiled. “But we should get started on that as soon as possible - we can’t let prisoners die or get taken over by a Goa’uld, right?”

No, they could not. To lose control of your body was a fate worse than death. Catra clenched her jaws, remembering Horde Prime.

“And once we have enough for everyone, people won’t get upset any more, right?” Entrapta smiled.

Catra scoffed again. “They’d still get upset because they don’t want one.”

“But no one would be forced to take one,” Entrapta pointed out.

“They would still get upset. It’s their thing.”

"It's not quite that bad, not for the majority, at least, but…" Daniel grimaced. "There is a vocal minority on Earth, divided into different groups, who think everyone should live their lives exactly like their particular group does."

A *very* vocal minority. "We can show you some recordings," Catra told Mermista. "But can we focus on the problems at hand?"

Really, she never had trouble with long meetings when she had been running the Horde. Of course, the whole thing had ended in utter failure, and it had been all her fault as the sole leader, unlike how things had been run in the Alliance…

She still hated those discussions and meetings, though, whether they were useful or not.

And this meeting seemed doomed to be stuck in the 'not useful' category.

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Outside the Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 14th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill shaded his eyes with his hand as he watched the sun set over the mountains in the distance. It looked very peaceful. If he squinted, he could spot, illuminated by the fading dusk, the hills where the Jaffa had been captured. If not for the noise from the base behind him, full of soldiers and vehicles, construction still going on in the perimeter, he could pretend he was alone on an alien planet, just enjoying the sunset. Almost like being in his cabin, just him and nature.

And footsteps behind him. He turned, hand on the carbine dangling from its sling. Sure, Carter and Entrapta had found no more Jaffa with their magic scanner, but Jack knew better than to assume that his only enemies were snakes. Even his friendship with the Etherians, who would investigate his death thoroughly, might not deter everyone he had pissed off in the past - and some of them had the resources to reach this planet. Not many, but…

"Jack?"

He sighed and relaxed. "Daniel?"

"Ah, there you are!" His friend appeared in the underbrush, pushing through with some difficulties. His woodcraft was still atrocious. Then again, he had spent most of his time in the wilderness in the desert.

"Yes, here I am. Enjoying the sunset." Jack swallowed the 'no longer alone' comment he wanted to add - Daniel would take it as an invitation to ask what was wrong.

"Ah, yes." Daniel nodded, brushed off a twig that had gotten stuck on his uniform, and joined him on the small ridge he had been using to shield himself from the base. "It's pretty," he commented after a moment of pushing his glasses up and fidgeting.

Jack sighed. "So, what brings you out here?" It couldn't be anything official, or Daniel would have told him straight away. If they had sent him out to fetch Jack in the first place, of course. So, it was something private.

"Ah…" Daniel cleared his throat.

"Out with it, Daniel, so I can continue to enjoy the sunset in peace."

"Well, I can leave and ask you later… it's not really, ah, time-critical…"

And Jack would wonder what his friend wanted to talk about - away from the others - for the rest of the evening. He shook his head. "Just ask away."

"Ah, OK." Daniel nodded. "So… This is what a war looks like, huh?"

Jack frowned. Daniel was still working himself up to talk about what he really wanted to ask. "Yep."

“Fleet battles, planetary invasions, fortresses being constructed, planets being liberated…” Daniel sighed.

“I didn’t think you had a problem with that.” Jack raised his eyebrows.

“I don’t!” Daniel retorted. “It’s just… today, it really hit me that Stargate Command is gone. I mean, not really gone, but…” He sighed and looked at Jack. “We’re not going to be working there anymore, exploring and, well, dealing with everything. SG-1 will be part of the army. If they even keep us around as a team. They might split us up! I mean, Sam’s been working with Entrapta almost full-time anyway, you’ve been busy training the new recruits, Teal’c’s been… well, he’s been helping you. I’m the only one who’s been doing what I’ve been doing all along.”

Ah, that was it. Daniel was maudlin about the future, even though he should know better. “They won’t split us up,” Jack told him.

“I’m not exactly a soldier, and this is a war.”

“We’ve been fighting a war since we started SG-1, and you did pretty well.” Jack smiled at him.

“Yes, I know, but, you know how things changed. We’ve got a fleet and an army now.” Daniel shrugged.

“And SG-1 will still be needed.” Jack snorted. “Hell, the Etherians are doing the same kind of missions we’ve been doing, and they have the fleet.”

“I’m not a magical princess.”

“And that’s a good thing,” Jack told him. “You’d look terrible in a dress. But we don’t need you for your fashion choices, but for your brain and people skills.”

Daniel winced. “Unless I get fired for spoiling the plans to colonise the planet.”

“You’ve seen the Etherians’ reaction to the whole thing. Do you think anyone will dare to piss them off?” Jack snorted again. “And if they do, you can work for the Etherians. Better pay and more freedom.”

“Right.” Daniel nodded, smiling a bit weakly. “I could do that.”

Jack hesitated a moment, then slapped him on the shoulder. “Cheer up. We’ve just liberated the first planet in the war. It’s time to celebrate.” And then to debrief everyone thoroughly so they won’t repeat the mistakes they had made in this invasion.

Daniel nodded again, more firmly. “Yes.”

Jack turned to look a the mountains. The sun had set now. “Let’s go back,” he said.

“Yes.”

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Educational Issues Part 1

Gate Area, Primary Mining Site, PZ-921, January 15th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and this is how you raise and lower the gate. If it's in the ground, it won't work, and no one can come through the gate." Entrapta gestured at the Stargate.

"I see." Sadiki nodded. "And what if this machine breaks?"

"Then you can lift it out with this fall-back pulley system we rigged up! Or you can ask Adora to pull it out. But only if she's here."

Adora managed not to wince at the looks she got from Sadiki and the others with him, but it took an effort. They probably only didn't fall to their knees because Daniel told them that she didn't like that. This was so… wrong. People shouldn't worship her.

"Or if I am here, I can lift out with ice!" Frosta added. And demonstrated by creating a pillar of ice under the gate that lifted it out of the hole.

"Let's hope the whole thing is waterproof," Catra mumbled next to Adora. "And solid enough to resist the ice."

It should be. And Entrapta didn't look worried. "Yes, like that," she said, nodding.

The stares switched to Frosta, who struck a pose and smiled in return. "I am Princess Frosta, ruler of the Kingdom of Snows. And I control the element of ice!"

Sadiki and his people bowed to her.

Adora gritted her teeth. That, too, felt wrong.

“Does that make her a demi-goddess?” Catra asked with a snort - though not loud enough to be overheard by Frosta, Adora noted. “Since she’s half your size?”

Glimmer chuckled. “I don’t think that’s how it works.”

“Ugh. Such a show-off,” Mermista complained.

“Someone is jealous,” Catra whispered with a grin.

Adora was forced to agree - it sounded as if Mermista would have liked to show off as well. She shook her head. This was so silly! And wrong. She wouldn’t have expected that from her friends.

They would have to talk about this once they were back home.

“Anyway, the machine should be good for a decade or so unless you damage it,” Entrapta went on. “And if you do damage it, you can still use the gate to call us - you know our address - and we’ll come and repair it. Or tell you how to repair it. Though you’d have to learn about mechanics for that. And a few other things, I guess. Not magic, though - the entire mechanism works without magic. Just in case you wondered.”

“Can… can we learn how to do magic? Like this?” one of the women asked. Adora didn’t remember her name, to her shame.

“If you have the talent. You can also learn how to use and make magitech, though you need even more knowledge for that,” Entrapta cheerfully explained.

“Yes. We are aware of how much we don’t know,” Sadiki said. He glanced at the others with him, and a few of them blushed. “And we are happy you have offered to teach us and our children what we need to know.”

“Wait until they get homework,” Catra whispered.

Adora frowned at her lover. They hadn’t had homework in the Horde. Just extra duties to study their material. Which was kind of

the same, but not quite. Not like what they had seen in Earth movies. "They know how important education is."

"And our allies know how important offering an education is. For them and our allies," Catra retorted with a cynical grin.

That was true, but Etheria wasn't prepared to teach so many people. Earth's education system, on the other hand, could absorb them easily - they had the teachers to spare, as Daniel had explained. Though he had also made a joke about people complaining about their own schools being neglected or something.

But the important thing was that Sadiki and his people would learn the things they needed to build better lives for themselves. Except for magic - Earth couldn't teach that. And Etheria… was still debating that.

"But while we appreciate you showing us how this works, the Chappa'ai will be operated by your soldiers, right?" Another man asked.

Sadiki glared at the man, but Entrapta nodded. "Yes. For now - unless you don't want us on the planet any more. Then we'd just keep a fleet in the system to defend you against the Goa'uld. Or anyone else, I guess."

Glimmer stepped forward. "This is just a temporary arrangement based on military necessity," she said. "But we are your guests - this is your world and your Stargate. We're here to help you, not rule you."

Sadiki nodded. "And we are grateful for your help."

"And they'll be even more grateful once they don't need our help any more," Catra whispered with another snort.

Adora rolled her eyes. Catra was sometimes a bit too cynical. There was no reason they couldn't become friends with Sadiki's people - they had common interests, after all.

"Well, that's good to hear - again. Can we go home now?" Mermista asked. "Not to rush anyone, but some of us have a kingdom to run."

She was a bit rude, but she was correct. They had a lot to discuss at home. About the invasion, what they learned from it, and about politics.

Adora wasn't looking forward to the latter part.

But she was looking forward to going home for a bit.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, January 15th, 1999

"...and so, in conclusion, the tactical deficiencies laid out earlier can be dealt with by more training and more experience. First priority should be more training for assaults with stealth shuttles," the Colonel finished.

"Thank you, Colonel O'Neill." General Percival nodded at him, then looked at Samantha Carter. "Captain Carter, what's your opinion about the lessons that should be drawn from this assault?"

Sam had already given her suggestions in her report. But she knew how this game was played, so she didn't tell the generals to read her report. She still made a point of pulling her report out. "From a technological and scientific point of view, a much closer cooperation with the Etherians and Tok'ra is needed. As we have seen, their technology and magic offer capabilities that Earth is lacking, which has repercussions for our training and tactics." They couldn't train as realistically if they didn't take their allies into account. The Colonel had already covered proposed changes to training, but he had focused on conventional aspects.

"I don't think we can expect the Etherian princesses to train with our soldiers," General Bryce commented. "Most of them are heads of state."

Sam disagreed. Daniel would be able to explain it much better, but he wasn't here. Neither was Teal'c. And the Colonel and Sam were, at least technically, only here as external advisors since they were still formally part of Stargate Command and not the Alliance. But that was mostly just a polite fiction. So, it fell to her to tell the general how their allies thought and fought. "I think that our allies would help with our training if we ask them, sir. That is what they are used to."

"Yep," the Colonel chimed in. "They're big on personally taking charge and charging in."

"In battle, yes. But we're talking about training," General Bryce retorted. "The Supreme Commander of the Alliance doesn't do duty as a drill sergeant."

"I bet his drill sergeant didn't like him," Sam heard the Colonel mutter under his breath.

She cleared her throat to hide her amusement. "The Etherian forces are structured and led differently, sir." Which he should know. "Princesses are expected to lead from the front and to personally deal with problems they might encounter - both in the military and civilian life. If we ask for their help with training our troops, they will help us."

"And become training instructors?" General Bryce still sounded doubtful.

Sam nodded. "Temporarily, at least. Until the structures for an improved training doctrine have solidified."

"I bet Netossa would be a great instructor," the Colonel added. "She has that vibe."

"And the experience," Sam said. "They did train their own troops."

"They didn't have nearly as many troops as we have," General Bryce objected.

“Most of our forces aren’t combat-ready yet,” General Percival pointed out. “And I think it would be a good idea to have our landing forces train with our allies. They will work closely with the Etherians.”

“If they agree, sure. But that will impact their ability to do their actual job.” General Bryce was frowning as he shrugged.

“But, speaking of shuttles…” General Müller spoke up. “We need more stealth shuttles. A lot more. Currently, only regular shuttles are in production. If we had sent our troops down with those shuttles, they wouldn’t have achieved tactical surprise and would likely have taken far greater casualties as a result.”

“Stealth shuttles require magitech,” Sam explained. “That technology requires far more extensive training to adapt to our factories and so shuttles with it will take a while to enter production.” Something the general should also be aware of already!

“Current plans assume we’ll put stealth shuttles into production once we launch our own spaceships,” General Percival said. “Until then, we’ll be relying on the Etherian space assets.”

And those spaceships were years from being commissioned - procurement was still quibbling over the exact specifications for the designs. And, according to what Sam had heard from her father, the yards in the United States were not too keen on joining the European consortium that would, apparently, handle their own design.

“Then we need to ask them for more stealth shuttles,” General Müller said.

“They’re aware of the need,” Sam told him. “But they have no such shuttles in mass production yet.” There was so much to do, and Entrapta and Sam - and Hordak - could only do so much.

“We need to take that into account when planning our next move,” General Soissant nodded.

"I'm sure Adora is aware of that," the Colonel said.

Sam nodded. They had plans to add stealth generators to conventional shuttles - not quite as effective as stealth shuttles built as such from the ground up, but still quite decent - but they would need help to set up a factory for those as well…

"You fight the war with the army you have, not the army you wish you had," General Bryce said, shrugging once more.

Sam pressed her lips together. That was a very callous attitude. She glanced at the Colonel and saw that he also seemed to restrain himself. They were here as advisors, she reminded herself. They were not even in the chain of command of the Alliance forces.

But that meant that she could go and talk to her Etherian friends about this without violating regulations or the chain of command…

*****

Bright Moon, January 15th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Ah, boring Alliance meetings in Bright Moon. How have I missed them!" Catra muttered as she arched her back on her seat and stretched her arms over her head.

Unfortunately, her lover wasn't paying attention - Adora wasn't frowning at her comment or staring at her chest while blushing. Instead, she was focusing on Glimmer's report from the intervention.

Catra sighed. Adora already knew every little detail of what Glimmer was telling the others.

"...and that was the end of the fighting, though we're faced with the challenge of keeping our prisoners alive and teaching them that they have been lied to."

Ah! Sparkles was finally done! Catra sat straighter for a moment, then leaned forward, resting her elbows on the table.

And *now* Adora was frowning at her? Catra rolled her eyes. Just not taking a nap while Glimmer rehashed the invasion was a huge achievement!

"I see." Netossa nodded. "I'll have to go over the detailed report to see if and how we need to adjust our training. Though without actual battle experience for our soldiers to base any changes on, we'll have to make a few guesses."

"We can ask the soldiers from Earth for their experiences," Bow suggested.

"That might help a little - but our forces are already trained to fight differently," Netossa told him. "They're used to fighting with Princesses leading them."

"Or fighting Princesses," Catra added. When half the table frowned at her, she flashed her fangs in a grin. "Just reminding you that a sizeable part of our forces is made up of former Horde soldiers. And their training is closer to what Earth soldiers get."

"Yes." Netossa, to her credit, didn't frown at her. "There is quite the overlap - but we've been training them to integrate with Princess Alliance forces since the war ended."

Since the Scorpion Kingdom was restored and it tuned out that most former Horde soldiers chose to follow Scorpia, meaning the new kingdom had one of the most powerful militaries of Etheria, Catra mentally added.

"Yeah!" Scorpia nodded. "I can say that they fight kind of like our guys. Mostly. I missed the bot and tank support, though they would have been of limited use inside the main building. And they would probably have been destroyed by the wave."

"Not if I had been with you from the beginning." Mermista sniffed. "I could have stopped that wave."

“Or I could have created ice dams to shield the base!” Frosta chimed in.

Mermista frowned at her, but Frosta raised her chin in that manner of hers that made her look like a petulant kid. Business as usual, then.

“While that is true, we can’t deploy everyone to every mission,” Glimmer told them.

“Just to every mission near water,” Mermista insisted with a grin.

“That wouldn’t really narrow it down,” Adora spoke up. “Most settled planets have large bodies of water.”

Mermista shrugged. “I’m ready to do my part. And with the Stargates, we can travel to every world we need to, across the entire galaxy, and still be back home for dinner.”

“Only if we have control of the Stargate in question,” Glimmer objected. “And the Goa’uld will fight the hardest to defend it.”

Of course, they would - most of their forces depended on the Stargate network for supply and transport.

“Then we can still help taking it and then return to Etheria,” Frosta said.

Mermista nodded again. “As long as we have the initiative and decide where to fight, we should concentrate our forces and hit with overwhelming power. Thanks to the Stargate network, we can quickly redeploy after an attack. We need to exploit this. The more princesses we can bring to bear, the easier the battles will be.”

“And the more vulnerable you’ll be.” Catra shook her head. “The Goa’uld aren’t stupid, and we won’t be able to keep them in the dark about our attacks forever. Once they realise what we are doing, they’ll prepare to counter us. And if a single trap can take out all of us…” She trailed off.

"If we had been there, their trap would have failed."

"That was one trap. What if there had been something else?" Adora nodded. "We can't just risk everyone like that."

"Like what?"

"Uh… A biological weapon? Or a chemical one? I could probably rig up a poison that won't show up on a scanner until it takes effect, though that would be cheating since I know what the scanners will detect, but it is possible for others to manage that as well." Entrapta frowned. "Sabotaging the Stargate is another option, I guess."

"Just trapping us on a planet without a working Stargate and forcing us to use ships to travel back would hinder an offensive planned with rapid redeployment in mind," Glimmer agreed.

"We can adapt to that when it happens. We still should use our advantage as long as possible," Mermista objected. "So we can get the most out of it. Hit as many planets before they wise up."

That wasn't a bad plan. But it wasn't a terribly good one either. Catra shook her head. "We aren't ready for such a campaign yet. We'd get strung out too much and would be stuck with defending too many systems while still trying to figure out how what to do about the liberated people. The Goa'uld don't care about killing civilians, so once they figure out we do, they will be able to force us to react to them." That was an obvious way to regain the initiative. Well, obvious if you had been trained in the Horde, Catra amended her thought.

"Yes." Adora nodded firmly. "We only struck this time because we needed to save those people. We need more time to prepare a proper campaign. More time to train and plan."

And that should have been obvious to everyone. "Victory disease is setting in early," Catra mumbled as the other princesses disagreed again. Well, it wasn't that bad, but still a concern. They weren't fighting on and for Etheria any more - the scope of this

war was far beyond the Princess Alliance's experiences. And Catra had her doubts that everyone was fully aware of that.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, January 16th, 1999

"...and while the official press release doesn't mention which planet was invaded, only that Alliance forces successfully liberated a planet under Goa'uld control, various experts have speculated that…"

Jack O'Neill pushed a button, and the channel in the mess hall changed.

"...how many people died in this invasion? If the casualties were as low as the government claims, then why can't we see footage from the battle? What is the government hiding? Or, rather, what are the aliens controlling our government hiding? We cannot trust…"

He pushed the button again. Harder. Why were those channels still available in the base?

"...and according to our sources, the people our soldiers died to liberate spurned our friendship and expelled us from their planet without lifting even a finger to support the war in return, showing such selfishness that it raises the question of whether the Alliance policy of self-determination can and should be enforced at this point in the war. It might be better to take an example from history, the Philippines, and…"

Jack muttered a curse and switched the channel again. Bryce and his carpetbagging backers at work, no doubt. And the newsies were probably still angry that they hadn't been allowed to cover the invasion live from the frontlines.

"What's with the television?"

“Someone broke it!”

“Stop changing channels all the time!”

“I’m not doing anything! We don’t even have the remote!”

“...and several leading news organisations have petitioned the Alliance command to allow embedded reporters with their forces, citing the need for independent information to both build trust and check for potential abuses in the war. So far, the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, Princess She-Ra, has declined to comment on the matter, prompting concerns about the freedom of the press being neglected. As some might not be aware, freedom of the press, even freedom of speech, is not a right on Etheria, so…”

Yeah, as I thought. Jack switched channels again.

“...and the last preparations of the Mission to Mars are now being finished, according to the NASA press release. Originally, it was planned to transport a habitat to Mars with an Alliance spaceship, but with interplanetary shuttles now produced on Earth for the war, it was decided that the first mission to Mars should be launched in a spaceship produced on Earth, with the habitat following afterwards. Now, let’s take a closer look at the multi-national crew chosen for this historic event!”

That was better. Jack wasn’t in the mood for more stupid rumours and thinly-veiled propaganda. Boring propaganda, at that. Not that the ‘Mission to Mars’ wasn’t propaganda either - they could have sent the first shuttle rolling off the new assembly lines to Mars as a test flight - but at least it was entertaining.

“Where did you get the remote for the TV, Jack?” Daniel asked in a low voice.

Jack slipped the remote into his pocket under the table and smiled his best ‘butter wouldn’t melt in my mouth’ smile at his friend. “What do you mean?”

Daniel rolled his eyes and went back to eating his lunch.

“Please don’t change the channel again, sir.”

Jack glanced at Carter. She was looking at the screen, apparently following the report quite attentively as it covered the various astronauts who would soon be - officially, at least - the first people on Mars. Was that a wistful smile? “You know, we could ask the Etherians to drop you off on Mars this afternoon if you want to be the first woman on Mars,” he half-joked - he had no doubt that Priest would do it if one of his goddess’s friends asked.

“Sir!” Carter frowned at him. “That would be an irresponsible abuse of power for egoistical reasons!”

“Yes?” Jack cocked his head and grinned.

“I believe that Captain Carter would consider it dishonourable to, as the saying goes, ‘steal the thunder’ of those astronauts by beating them to Mars,” Teal’c commented.

As usual, Teal’c was hard to read, but Jack was sure that his friend didn’t really believe he had to explain Carter’s opinion to Jack. Still… “It’s just showboating. They’ve even delayed moving the habitat just so they can pretend that they are doing this on their own. I guess the ‘to boldly take a taxi where no one took a taxi before’ skit on SNL was one joke too much.”

“It’s the principle of the thing, sir.” Carter was still frowning at him. “Using a shuttle built on Earth means that the mission will not require outside assistance.”

Jack shrugged. “Sure, but it’s still an Etherian shuttle design we basically copy. One we have been using to ferry troops and officers around for a few weeks now.”

“We haven’t left Earth’s orbit, though,” Carter retorted. “This will be Earth’s first interplanetary mission.”

"I do seem to remember visiting another star system a few years ago…" Jack grinned again.

Carter didn't pout, but the way she narrowed her eyes at him in exasperation was almost as good. "You know what I mean, sir."

"Sure I do." He shrugged. "I'm just not too impressed by the hype. Though it's better than listening to people pushing their agenda on the news." Kinsey was probably involved in half those stories leaking to the press.

"Well, they do have some legitimate concerns. The Etherians don't have the concept of 'freedom of the press'," Daniel said. "They don't have what we would consider modern news media, actually. So, they could be ignoring the issue of independent reporting."

"Well, announcing military secrets to the world isn't a good idea," Jack said. Even though Vietnam hadn't been lost because the press had been turning people back home against the war, as some claimed, it certainly hadn't helped. "But I guess some embedded reporters won't hurt too much." It had worked well in the Gulf War.

"They're also pushing for a visit to Etheria," Daniel told him. "So do many of my colleagues, actually."

Well, that was the Etherians' problem, not Jack's. Though it might be fun to see what kind of stories reporters could dig up in the land of rainbows and unicorns if let loose.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, January 17th, 1999

"...and we're all in agreement that there'll be a special task force working on deprogramming the prisoners, recruited amongst experienced people in the field." Adora looked at the generals present as they nodded, then glanced at the aide de camp taking notes.

"Finally!" Catra muttered next to her. "That shouldn't have taken so long. Even a gaggle of princesses would have been faster."

Adora suppressed a wince. Her lover was probably correct. But then, this was an important task, and Adora knew that it didn't pay to rush important decisions without thinking them through and getting the opinions of others. Catra should know this as well, given her past, but pointing that out would be… unkind and pointless. Catra was just venting her frustration, and pretty subtly at that - at least for her.

"Next item: Embedded reporters," General Naird said, shuffling the papers in front of him. According to Jack, Naird was only on this council because he had been commanding Air Force Space Command, and they wanted an Air Force general in the spot, and with General Hammond still stuck in Stargate Command, Naird was the next-not-too-bad choice. But he seemed competent enough and quite nice personally to Adora.

"Embedded reporters?" Catra asked, cocking her head. Adora knew she had read the briefing papers for this meeting, so she was faking her ignorance.

Naird, though, did seem to take her at face value. Or he was just too polite to comment on it. "Yes. The leading news services of the United States and its allies have petitioned Alliance Command - that's us - to allow embedded reporters to cover the war."

"You mean propagandists?" Catra asked, in the same tone she usually denied being responsible for whatever had gone wrong in one of their Horde cadet exercises.

The way Naird frowned at her told Adora that, this time, he had seen through Catra's act. "They are news services, not propaganda organisations. The United States and its allies do not control their media."

"I didn't mean their government propaganda organisations," Catra retorted with a toothy grin. "But they're definitely spewing

propaganda." She leaned back. "Trust me, I've been raised on that stuff."

Adora pressed her lips together but nodded in agreement. "Several of those news services do show clear biases in their reporting."

"Well, that's a matter of opinion, though one could argue that truly unbiased reporting is impossible due to the observer effect…" Naird trailed off under the glances of the others in the room. "At least, that's what my friend says."

"Leaving philosophical or physical questions aside, I don't think we can keep the press out of the war," the American Secretary of Defense said, frowning at Naird. "But we can handle that like we did in the Gulf War."

"I don't think they'll accept such strict limitations," the British Secretary of State for Defence said. "Especially since, unlike the Gulf War, this won't be over in a month. You can't control the press for so long."

"Maybe not yours," the American shot back.

"Control of the press goes against the fundamental principles of a democracy."

"Military necessity trumps freedom of the press. Without information security, we will not be able to effectively fight a war," the American retorted. "And with the war spreading to other worlds, we cannot count on Earth's isolation to keep news from reaching our enemies forever."

"If we act like a totalitarian regime, we will lose the support of the population, which will endanger the war effort much more than the occasional leak on Earth," the British official pointed out.

"I would hardly call basic military procedures to control sensitive information a totalitarian move. It's just common sense."

"If we don't give them the news, they'll find something to publish that we don't have any control over."

"Or they make something up," Glimmer cut in. "We've been following the news coverage of the last mission." She leaned forward. "And it was quite easy to tell which news organisation was owned by someone with an interest in exploiting the planet."

Adora nodded with a scowl. "And we haven't forgotten which of your media portrayed us and people like us as monsters." It would be easier to simply forbid any reporters from joining their forces. But Mister Brown and Julie had assured them that that would be 'counter-productive', and they were the experts.

Both the American and the British officials flushed a little while their French and German counterparts looked a bit smug. Naird shuffled his papers some more before speaking up again: "Any embedded war correspondents will have to be thoroughly vetted, of course."

"Of course." Catra grinned. "But who does the vetting?"

"We have people with the experience for that task," Naird says. "And I assume you have such people as well?"

"Yes." Glimmer nodded.

Adora didn't think Alliance spy hunters had quite the same experience as the Earth specialists, given the differences between their worlds, but it was probably good enough. If you could deal with the likes of Double Trouble, picking out honest reporters shouldn't be too hard.

"So, that's settled as well." Naird marked something on his papers. "Next item: Recruiting, screening for and training magically talented people."

That again. Adora sighed.

“That’s the purview of Mystacor on Etheria,” Glimmer said. “They pick their students.”

“And they have offered to train our soldiers, haven’t they?”

Catra chuckled. “Castaspella offered to train Colonel O’Neill.”

“He’s the first soldier known to have a magical talent, right?” Naird asked.

“He’s a special case,” Glimmer said with a frown aimed at Catra. “Similar cases might receive the same invitation, but we don’t know any yet.”

“We haven’t made a lot of progress with screening for magical talent,” the Frech Minister commented. “We would be grateful for any assistance in that area.”

“We’ll pass it on to Mystacore,” Glimmer said.

Adora nodded again. They had to talk with the sorcerers anyway. About this, and a few other things.

“Great. Next item: Commendations. Several members of the Alliance forces have distinguished themselves in the recent combat and deserve recognition…”

Catra groaned, a bit louder this time, but Naird went on.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, January 18th, 1999

Jack sighed as he watched the Stargate. It was almost time. “You know, I don’t see why we should be here - the Tok’ra want to discuss Alliance matters, and Stargate Command is not part of the Alliance forces. We’re just the gatekeepers and gophers for the United Nations.” He had better things to do than greet alien visitors.

Daniel frowned at him. “We’ve been working closely with the Alliance - SG-1, I mean. We’ve fought in the first Alliance combat mission. I don’t think you can claim we aren’t part of the Alliance forces.”

“Being temporarily detached to other forces doesn’t change that we’re still under United Nations command,” Jack retorted. He knew his regs - the better to bend and twist them.

“That’s a fig leaf. We also were part of the delegation that negotiated the Alliance. And didn’t you tell me you expect us to be transferred to Alliance command anyway?” Daniel pouted.

“Yep. But all that doesn’t mean we should stand here to greet aliens.” Jack wasn’t pouting. He was better than that.

Daniel frowned. “Don’t tell me you’re afraid of meeting Anise, Jack!”

“I’m not afraid of meeting the mad scientist snake, Daniel.” Jack simply would prefer not to meet her. Not until she accepted - preferably in writing - that he wasn’t going to have a baby with her. Or with anyone else. Or with test tubes. Or clone pods. He wasn’t going to have kids, period. Not if they were just wanted for their - his - Ancient genes. “But we do have better things to do than meeting and greeting people we’ve already met before.”

“It’s called being polite and welcoming to our allies.” Daniel’s frown deepened.

“Yeah, and others can do that better.” Jack wasn’t feeling very polite and friendly. And why were the snakes visiting anyway? They had mentioned a ‘potential issue for the Alliance’ when they had called ahead, but they hadn’t mentioned what issue it was.

Not that it was Jack’s business, anyway. He wasn’t a politician or a general. Unless you could shoot it or blow it up, it wasn’t his problem. Or shouldn’t be.

That was his story, and he would be sticking to it. Although you could solve a lot of problems by shooting them or blowing them up.

He glanced to his side. Teal'c was doing his 'stoic waiting' thing. And Carter was… in her lab with the other alien mad scientist they knew. Apparently, being a genius working to develop new technology was enough to get out of greeting duty. Jack would have to take notes.

"We're being dialled," Siler announced. "Codes match the Tok'ra."

"Open the iris," General Haig ordered.

A moment later, the iris retracted, and the wormhole vortex formed.

"Wormhole stable."

"Send the go-ahead."

"Yes, sir."

A moment later, two people stepped through the gate, and Jack had to suppress a groan. Anise and Martouf? The snake after Jack's genes, and the snake pining for Carter? This was shaping up to be one of those days he should have called in sick! "We should have claimed that the gate's down for maintenance," he muttered as the two Tok'ra walked down the ramp.

"Since we communicated through the wormhole, I think that they wouldn't have believed us," Daniel pointed out.

"Yeah, but would they have called us out? They might have decided to directly talk to the princesses instead!" Jack whispered. Come to think of it, why were they coming to Earth instead of Etheria? Sure, the Alliance Headquarters was on Earth, but everyone knew where the real power in the Alliance was located.

But here they were. Time to lie and smile. “Marty! Anise! How nice to see you!” Jack said as he stepped forward.

“Jack! It’s Martouf!” Daniel whispered behind him as if Jack wasn’t aware of that. Hey, if he was the ranking officer in the gate room and had to greet new arrivals, he would do it his way. Otherwise, they might think he liked doing this.

“And it’s nice to see you, Jack!” Anise beamed at him, and Jack had to struggle not to wince.

“Yes, it’s a pleasure to see you again,” Martouf added. He was - none too subtly - looking around, though.

“Captain Carter’s busy in her lab,” Jack told him with a genuine smile. “You know how it is - science takes priority over politics.”

“Ah.”

“Of course it does!” Anise nodded. “But the issue we need to talk about concerns Sam - and science.”

Oh. Jack narrowed his eyes. If this was just a pretext for Martouf to hassle Carter, then Jack would have to be a bit undiplomatic.

*****

“Hello, Sam.”

“Good morning, Captain Carter.”

“Anise? Martouf?” Carter sounded surprised, Jack noted as they entered her lab.

“Hi, guys!” A holoprojection of Entrapta standing next to Carter waved at everyone. With her arms, hair and a few metal arms in the lab - waldos, the name was, he reminded himself.

“Hello, Entrapta.” Anise returned the greeting.

“Princess Entrapta.” Martouf gave her a nod, already focused on Carter.

“Hi, Entrapta.” Daniel beamed at her.

“Greetings.” Teal’c nodded politely.

Jack cleared his throat. “Yeah, hello, everyone. Marty and Anise here came to talk about a ‘potential issue for the Alliance’ related to your work, Carter.”

“Oh?” She seemed surprised.

“A potential issue? Do you need our help? We’ve got a full schedule, but we could probably shuffle a few things around. The spy bot network is growing according to our projections and doesn’t need too much supervision, so we could delay the next version, and we could also probably wait with the construction bots for the stealth modules for shuttles for a week or so since we still haven’t perfected the mining bots to feed the automated factory station we’re designing.” Entrapta beamed at their guests.

Jack made a mental note to look into those projects she had mentioned. They sounded… well, he wasn’t a geek, but automated factories manned by bots, fed by mining bots… that sounded like a Cameron movie about a robot uprising in the making.

“It’s actually about your plan to create ‘dumb symbionts’,” Anise said. She wasn’t smiling any more.

“Oh! You’ve got the message!” Entrapta nodded, still smiling happily. “Do you have a genetic sample? We could use one of the samples from the prisoners we have, but it might be safer to use a sample without the genetic memory of a Goa’uld, even though we probably would remove it anyway.”

Jack blinked. They had asked the Tok’ra to donate a genetic sample to create dumb symbionts to save the Jaffa prisoners?

“We have a few concerns about your plan,” Martouf said. Very diplomatically.

Anise nodded with a not-so-diplomatic expression.

And Jack had to struggle not to laugh out loud. It was different when the shoe was on the other foot, was it?

*****

Mystacor, Etheria, January 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Mystacor hadn’t changed at all since their last visit, Adora noted. Or, rather, they had repaired whatever damage it had suffered in the war and restored the island exactly as it had been before, so it looked untouched by the war.

Which probably said something about the sorceresses ruling the floating island.

“Auntie!”

“Glimmer!” Castaspella lifted Glimmer up in a hug that made Adora smile and also feel a bit sad - or jealous. “So nice of you to visit! It’s been too long!”

“You were staying in Bright Moon for months.”

“That’s not the same. It’s been too long since you visited.”

“I would like to visit more often, but with the war…”

“The stress from the war is even more of a reason to visit and relax, Glimmer!”

At Adora’s side, Catra sighed. Loudly. She was rolling her eyes as well.

Both Castaspella and Glimmer turned to frown at Adora’s lover, and Adora stepped forward to head off any barbs. “Hello, Castaspella. Thank you for having us visit.”

“You’re always welcome here,” Castaspella replied with a smile. “Although, since I doubt you were visiting to enjoy our beaches and hot springs, let’s move to my office so we can have tea while we talk.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. They were here to discuss politics, after all. All sorts of politics.

Castaspella led them through the marble hallway, past a group of what looked like students - they were young, younger than Adora had been in the Horde war, at least, and stared and whispered. Fortunately, Catra didn’t try to startle or hiss at them - sometimes, she did that when she felt annoyed.

Once inside Castaspella’s office - which was as large as Adora and Catra’s room in the palace, but sorceresses probably needed the space for their spells and experiments - they sat down at a small table, and at a gesture from Castaspella, a tray bearing tea and snacks floated over.

“So, what do we have to discuss?” Castaspella asked while their cups were being filled and Catra looked for fish sandwiches amongst the snacks.

Adora and Glimmer exchanged a glance. “It’s about teaching students from other planets,” Adora said after a moment. “We have restored magic to another planet, and we will continue to do so, so there will be more people in need of training.” Straight and to the point. Like Adora preferred it herself.

“Not nearly as many as Earth will add over time, though,” Castaspella replied before taking a sip from her cup.

“No.” Glimmer nodded. “But this might change over time. But even so… We need to know if Mystacor will train selected students from other worlds. I know you offered to teach Jack, but…” She trailed off.

“...but he’s a ‘special case’,” Catra finished for her with a grin.

Adora took a sip herself to mask her expression. She didn't think Castaspella was trying to seduce Jack by offering him training, but there were rumours. Rumours which Catra was not so subtly hinting at.

"He's got a lot of potential," Castaspella said, all cool and collected. "And he is a First One, or close enough. It would be a shame not to see this potential nurtured and trained." With a glance at Catra, she added: "I have no intention to start a relationship with him, which I think I made already clear. Not only do I not desire him in that way, but to start a relationship with a student… it would violate everything Mystacor stands for."

Catra made a noncommittal noise in return, her mouth filled with probably all the fish sandwiches from the tray.

Glimmer cleared her throat. "So, Mystacor is open to exceptional students only?"

Castaspella sighed. "Certain teachers are willing to accept special students. As a whole, we cannot teach many more than our usual amount of pupils. We simply don't have the numbers and resources to take on everyone from Earth with the talent. We could expand our numbers, but… that is a controversial issue. As is refusing Etherian students in favour of those from other planets. The best we can realistically do is teach those who have the most potential and let them teach others. "

That… didn't sound as bad as Adora had feared.

"It would be years before that started to bear fruits," Glimmer said.

Castaspella nodded.

"And you haven't picked any such students yet," Catra pointed out.

"We don't know any such students except for Jack. And looking for them on Earth…" Castaspella inclined her head and took

another sip from her cup. “We are used to having students come to us after discovering their talents. And what we know of Earth’s attitude towards magic raises some concerns.”

“Well, people from Earth can’t exactly come to Mystacor - or Etheria - that easily,” Glimmer said. “Security prohibits that.”

“But they would like your help to screen their people for sorceresses,” Adora added.

Cataspella grimaced for a moment. “I know a few sorceresses who would like to visit Earth anyway, and they might be willing to look for potential students. There has been a debate in the council about that.”

“I haven’t heard about that,” Glimmer commented.

“They are curious about Earth’s magic traditions and want to study them. And their artefacts,” Castaspella added.

Oh.

Catra snorted. “They want to exploit Earth’s magic?”

“I wouldn’t put it like that, but… most of those who voiced such plans seem most interested in gaining more knowledge rather than spreading it.” Castaspella spread her hands. “I don’t think they would be the best ambassadors for our kingdom and academy.”

Ah. Adora nodded.

“Yeah, we don’t want to look like colonialists,” Glimmer agreed.

“But then you’re going to look like elitists unwilling to share your knowledge,” Catra commented.

“Several of my colleagues wouldn’t mind that,” Castaspella retorted. “We’re trying to find a compromise, but… it’s a delicate process.”

“Meaning, you don’t think it’ll work.” Catra snorted.

“It is too early to say that, but Mystacor’s politics and policies usually take a long time to change.”

“Time we don’t really have.” Glimmer shook her head. “If Mystacor as a whole won’t do anything, we need to talk to individuals.”

“That might be a more promising approach, but it might also cause additional tensions within the kingdom,” Castaspella said.

“You sound like a diplomat from Earth explaining why they can’t do the sensible thing.” Catra shook her head.

Castaspella chuckled in return, even though it wasn’t really funny in Adora’s opinion.

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Educational Issues Part 2

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States, Earth, January 18th, 1999

"..and while the benefits such a 'dumb symbiont' would provide are obvious, there are several important issues with this proposal you might not have considered, in our opinion," Martouf said.

His expression lacked the usual subtle longing when he was looking at her, Samantha Carter noticed.

"Like that having such an option would compete with Tok'ra recruitment?" the Colonel cut in.

"That is one of our concerns, yes." Martouf nodded at him. "Although only one, and not the most important."

Sam could see the issue there, of course. How many potential hosts would want to share their body with a Tok'ra if there was an alternative that provided most of the benefits while the recipient retained full control over their body? But she was sure that there were enough potential hosts even if the symbionts would reach a level of advancement where their benefits were equal to those granted by a Tok'ra symbiont.

"There is also the fact that you would basically create a new, dumb species from a Goa'uld or Tok'ra template," Anise said. "Imagine if, say, we would want to create 'dumb hosts' using your DNA as a base. Human origin, but deliberately reduced in sapience to the level of an animal."

Sam drew a surprised breath through her clenched teeth. She hadn't considered this - she and Entrapta were planning to experiment with a fellow sapient species. If they were doing this with humans… She grimaced as she suddenly felt slightly ill. How had she missed this? She should have seen this! It was unethical!

Daniel looked struck as well. And why hadn't he realised this? Had he been so busy with trying to keep Sadiki's people from being exploited to miss this?

"Uh…" Entrapta, unfortunately, looked confused. "I thought you needed sapient hosts."

Martouf grimaced as well. "It was merely an example."

"Imagine if we would create brainless clones from humans to use as donors for organ transplants," Sam said.

"Oh." Entrapta blinked. Then she tilted her head to the side and looked at Sam. "But without a brain, it's not a human, right?"

"I think that is disproven by several politicians and pundits I know," the Colonel quipped. But he didn't look like he actually was amused any more - he looked a bit queasy himself, Sam noticed.

"He's joking," she told Entrapta.

"Ah." Her friend nodded. "But without a brain, it's just… biomass shaped like a human. Not even a proto-human."

Sam sighed softly. Entrapta was one of the nicest women she knew, a great friend and a brilliant scientist, but she struggled with some things. Such as certain ethical questions. Of course, some questions everyone struggled with. "It's not that simple," she said. "If someone suffers brain damage, they're still a human. No matter how much brain damage they suffer." Of course, there was also the question of when exactly someone became a human in the first place, but that question had been answered pretty succinctly as 'at birth', for a variety of sound reasons, and Sam didn't give a damn about those who disagreed with this - she knew exactly what those people actually wanted when they tried to redefine when a fetus became a human.

"And if they die?"

“Then they are a dead human. But they don’t stop being a human,” Sam replied. “And if we started treating humans who aren’t smart enough as not human, then that could have dire consequences.”

“Yeah.” The Colonel looked very serious. “Some people would jump at the chance to draw a line like that and then do away with those who wouldn’t be considered human anymore. And they might be a little fuzzy about where they would draw the line.”

“Yes.” Daniel nodded firmly. “It’s not a line we want to cross. History teaches us what happens when humans are considered subhumans.”

Entrapta still looked confused. “Which part of history do you mean?”

“Slavery and the Holocaust are the most known,” Daniel replied.

“Ah. Oh.” Entrapta’s eyes widened. “You mean… This would lead to people murdering each other?”

“Ah…” Daniel winced. “Not directly. But it’s a concern - it’s mostly an example to show why it’s bad to experiment with humans. Or Tok’ra. Or Goa’uld. Any sapient species, actually.”

“And horses, I guess,” the Colonel added. “At least according to Swift Wind.”

“This is a very simplified view. There are other ethical questions we haven’t touched, and human cells are used in experiments by scientists on Earth, although some consider that unethical as well,” Daniel said.

“Oh.” Entrapta slowly nodded. “So, if we just use the cells, that would be OK?”

Daniel grimaced again. “As I said, it’s a very complex issue. Using human - or Goa’uld - cells for research is generally considered

alright. But creating an organism based on those cells for experimentation… That's a much murkier question."

"So, it's a matter of intent." Entrapta nodded again. "And it means we have to find another way to save the Jaffa we captured than what we originally planned. But we can use cells for research as long as we don't clone actual specimens out of them. Or clone specimens for experimentation. We need an artificial symbiont, then."

"Most will agree with that view, yes." Daniel smiled.

Her friend was correct, though Sam would still expect some backlash if those experiments were publicised. Although if they managed to create an artificial symbiont, then the majority of the people would want to use it and would likely silence dissenters.

Entrapta pouted. "That will be more difficult than I thought, then. We won't be able to use an existing working template and alter it - we'll have to build up an organism from scratch that will emulate the effects. And we can only use the cell samples from Goa'uld as models, not as a source, since we need a non-sapient organism not based on any sapient species." Entrapta nodded again. "I think we need to visit Alpha for that."

"The Ancient AI?" Anise beamed at them.

"Yes. Want to visit?" Entrapta matched their friend's smile.

"I would be delighted!"

Sam winced. She didn't have to look at the Colonel to know that he was scowling.

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Bright Moon, Etheria, January 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and that's why we need to go to the First Moon of Enchantment!" Entrapta finished her explanation. "We need to talk

to Alpha about the First Ones' research into genetic engineering so we can help the Jaffa without experimenting with people. Because that's bad, but creating a new life form not based on people is good."

Catra blinked, then nodded. It made sense. Sort of. And, of course, Entrapta would bring her friends from the Tok'ra along without asking beforehand. And SG-1 would tag along.

"I see." Glimmer slowly nodded.

"We hadn't considered that!" Adora, though, shook her head. "We should have realised that this was bad. I should haOw…"

Catra rolled her eyes as she withdrew her leg. "Don't blame yourself for everything, idiot." If the others wanted to feel guilty, that was their problem - Sam certainly looked like she did - but Catra wouldn't let Adora blame herself for this.

Adora rubbed her calf - which wasn't even bleeding; Catra knew how to use her claws - and pouted at her. "But I should have realised that this was wrong."

"Well, no one realised it." O'Neill shrugged. "Not even Daniel, and that's usually his thing."

Daniel grimaced instead of laughing at the comment.

Catra sighed. "Nobody's perfect, we all should have realised that experimenting with people to make a new life form is bad since the First Ones did it, we won't do it, blah blah blah. No one did actually do it, so no harm done. You were talking about heading to Research Station Alpha?"

Adora pouted some more at her, and Martouf frowned, but everyone else seemed to be ready to move on. Good.

"Yes!" Enttapta, unfazed by the whole issue, nodded. "And we need Glimmer's permission since it's her moon. And Adora and Jack's, since it's their base. Well, it's Alpha's base, but she answers

to you. And we need a shuttle to fly there. So… we need quite a few things."

"Of course, you have my permission to travel to the First Moon of Enchantment," Glimmer said. Then she blinked. "Although… you're not going to start experimenting there, are you?"

"Oh, could we?" Anise beamed at her. "To work in a research base of the Ancients…"

"Research Station Alpha is where the people of Etheria were born, kind of," Bow told her. "It is of immense historical and cultural importance."

Catra doubted that most people on Etheria shared that view - or were aware of the base - but Anise looked suitably taken aback.

"Oh, yes, I understand," she said, grimacing. "Still, the knowledge to be found there, the inspiration…" She sighed.

Catra suppressed a snort at O'Neill's expression.

"Yes!" Entrpata nodded enthusiastically. "Alpha could have immensely helpful data! And it'll be good to talk to her again - she might feel lonely on the moon."

"She's been talking with my dads," Bow said. "They're working on a book on the creation of Etheria."

"That's nice!" Adora smiled.

Bow nodded. "They said they had to distract themselves when we were gone for so long."

And Adora's face fell. Catra glared at Bow, who had the grace to blush. "Err… well, they usually fly with a shuttle from Second Fleet, so… we can ask them to hitch a ride?" he suggested.

"Yeah, let's go." Catra stood. "And we can ask them about their book as well." Bow looked surprised, so she rolled her eyes and

added: “Because I think we’ll need to know if the book will start a ruckus on Etheria.”

“Oh.”

The way most of her friends looked surprised at her comment wasn’t a good sign.

At least Glimmer was on the ball - then again, she was a queen. “Yes. Princess Sweet Bee will probably consider it propaganda or try to claim the base ‘for all of Etheria’ - or both. Probably both.” She scowled.

“Well, realising that you’re the result of an experiment by the Ancients can be a shock to people,” Daniel said. “It certainly would be on Earth.”

“Heh, just realising that you’re not alone in the universe was a great shock to you,” Catra pointed out. “Or that magic is real.”

“Well…” Daniel shrugged.

“Yeah, yeah, it was a big shock, and we got over it. Those who matter, at least. Let’s hope you’ll get over having started as ‘test subjects’, as the computer in the station told us,” O’Neill said.

Catra narrowed her eyes at him. “Yeah, Mister First One.” When he glared at her, she flashed her fangs at him in return. At least on Etheria, people didn’t expect you to follow their stupid religion’s rules about who you were allowed to love.

“Let’s just go meet your dads and ask if we can tag along with them, OK?” Adora smiled.

“Yes.”

Martouf and Anise looked a bit confused. Catra’s ears twitched as she caught them whispering to each other. Ah, they wondered why they weren’t taking a shuttle from Bright Moon.

Well, wasn't there a saying that to confuse your enemies, you had to start with your allies, or something?

*****

The First Moon of Enchantment, January 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill considered himself to be a tolerant man. Different strokes for different folks was a perfectly fine way to live your life. What consenting adults did in the privacy of their homes, and with whom, was their business, and none of Jack's, or anyone else's. But some lines shouldn't be crossed in public, no matter whether you were an alien or not, and Bow's parents… Jack forced himself to smile and tried not to look at Lance and George as their shuttle entered their final approach to Research Site Alpha's hangar. They were just so… Well, public displays of affection were OK, even if Jack didn't like seeing two men his age exchange glances straight out of a romance novel. But Lance…

You didn't wear socks with sandals! That was a universal rule, no matter what Daniel claimed. Just ask anyone who had ever met a German tourist!

"And here we are! Hello, Alpha!" Bow's taller dad announced as they stepped out of the shuttle.

"Hello, Lance. Hello, George." A projection of the computer appeared in front of the ramp. Smiling widely.

"Hello, Alpha!" George smiled. "Did you finish refurbishing the new area?"

"I did, yes. Hello, Adora, Colonel O'Neill." The projection bowed towards them, then turned to address the others. "Entrapta. Glimmer. Bow. Catra. Daniel Jackson. Samantha Carter. Teal'c." Then she cocked her head. "There are two people infected with parasites with you. Should I remove them before they contaminate the site, or are they test subjects? Should I set up a containment area?"

Jack blinked, then snorted - and had to remind himself that having the two snakes locked up by the Ancient computer would be a terrible faux pas since they were allies. Even though it would be funny.

“Uh, no, they are our guests, Alpha,” Adora said, looking flustered. “They aren’t parasites but Symbionts - they aren’t Goa’uld but Tok’ra.”

“According to my scans, they match all the parameters that define a Goa’uld.”

“That’s just, uh, biological. But they really aren’t Goa’uld, and it’s rude to mix them up.”

“My scanners aren’t set to detect non-biological differences. This presents a grave security threat. I suggest treating them as Goa’uld and detaining them until a verifiable method to differentiate them from Goa’uld can be implemented.”

Alpha was his kind of girl, Jack decided. Computer. Whatever.

“We oppose the Goa’uld. We are not like them!” Anise protested. Her voice changed, and Freya added: “We are partners.”

“That is a verbal statement which cannot be proven or disproven with the currently available data.”

That was the computer version of ‘of course a Goa’uld would say that’, Jack guessed.

Catra snorted behind him.

“They’re our friends. Register them as that!” Adora ordered.

The projection turned to look at Jack.

Was it waiting for him in case he wanted to countermand this? He nodded. “Uh, yes, register them as friends.” He ignored the smile aimed at him by Anise.

“Very well. Please state your names for the data banks.” The projection managed to sound like a suffering clerk.

“We are Anise and Freya.”

“Lantash and Martouf.”

“Noted.”

Lance coughed. “Now that that’s settled, let’s proceed to the archives, shall we?

“Of course.” Alpha bowed again. “I’ve prepared the records you asked for.”

“Oh, great! You found them?” Lance beamed at the projection.

“Yes.”

“Were they misfiled?” George asked.

“Yes.” The projection frowned. “The mistake has been corrected.” Once more, she turned to look at Jack and Adora. “I recommend logging a reprimand for the person responsible, Assistant Researcher Talar Junas. Faulty or misfiled data is unacceptable in a research site.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “If you can’t trust your data, you can’t trust your experiment! It’s sabotaging science!”

She sounded as if that was a much worse crime than taking over someone’s body, Jack couldn’t help feeling. He glanced at Carter, who nodded in agreement. No joking about it, then. So he shrugged. “Well, we don’t know if that Talar guy - or girl - is still alive to get reprimanded, but if we see them…” He shrugged, then winced when Adora briefly looked sad. No joking about the death of her people.

“Noted.” Behind the projection, the door opened. “Will you join Lance and George in the archives?”

“It’s a lovely place,” Lance told them with a smile. “We’ve remodelled, so it’s much more comfortable now. Alpha did a great job.”

“Enhancing a workplace’s ergonomics is a logical way to improve the efficiency of the workers,” Alpha added. But she sounded rather pleased.

Damn. Jack pressed his lips together. Now he was, what was the word, humanising machines?

“Oh, nice!” Entrapta beamed. “Let’s go check it out! We can check the research data there for our project!”

Alpha perked up. “I stand ready to assist with any and all research projects,” she announced.

“Uh, that’s good:” Adora smiled a bit weakly. “We can use the help, I think. But… ask us before you assist with potentially dangerous experiments, OK?”

“Define ‘dangerous’, please.”

Alpha had been built by people who created a planet full of ‘test subjects’ and were willing to destroy it and a big part of the entire sector to win a war, Jack reminded himself.

“Uh… anything that could hurt people if it went wrong?” Adora asked more than answered.

“Define ‘hurt’, please. Almost any action, even a purely verbal one, has the potential to hurt someone.”

Adora looked at Jack.

Jack looked at Daniel. Explaining things so that the nice computer wouldn’t accidentally wipe out a world or two trying to help mad scientists sounded like the perfect job for Jack’s friend. And it might help him stop feeling sorry for not catching the troublesome nature of Entrapta and Carter’s original plans.

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"...so, it's a matter of scale. An experiment that could lead to negative consequences for a single person's mental or physical health is not problematic, but if more people are potentially affected, it requires approval from a legitimate authority." Alpha nodded.

Adora winced. That wasn't entirely what they wanted Alpha to understand. Perhaps they should have asked Lance and George to help, but Bow's dads were already in the archives, researching their own project.

"Not quite," Daniel tried again. "In the first case, it's only not problematic if said person gave consent to the experiment - and if it was an informed decision, meaning the person at risk was aware of the danger and the probability of a negative outcome."

"Ah." Once more, Alpha's projection nodded.

"Yes! You need reliable data to deduce anything! That's how science works!" Entrapta chimed in with a happy smile.

Adora glanced at Sam and Anise, who also nodded in agreement.

"But experiments are how you gather data. If you already had reliable data about the outcome, there would be no need for the experiment in the first place," Alpha said.

That was… well, it was true, but still not correct.

"That's correct, yes." Sam nodded. "But you don't need to know the results of an experiment to make informed decisions about it - you just need reliable estimates of the range of potential consequences."

"Blast radius, for example," Entrapta added. "Calculate the blast radius based on the materials involved so you can determine the safe distance." She cocked her head. "Of course, stuff like Naquadah-enhancements to explosives kind of mess with that, so

you should start with tiny quantities and do it in space where shockwaves don't travel well and slowly build up your data."

"Yes." Daniel glanced at Jack, Adora noted. "If you're experimenting with explosives, you should start small. Very small."

"Almost anything can be an explosive if used correctly. Or incorrectly," Anise cut in. "And some processes need to overcome a threshold to result in an explosion."

"Yes," Sam agreed again. "Critical mass."

"I think we were talking about genetic engineering, not explosives," Jack commented. "Unless you want to create explosive tomatoes."

"Well, biological explosives are entirely possible," Entrapta said, scrunching her nose. "Many explosive materials could be grown. It wouldn't be very efficient compared to mass-processing in chemical plants, but it's possible." She perked up. "And if it is a plant, Perfuma should be able to control it, so that would add instant mass-production potential to it!"

Perfuma letting explosive plants sprout from the ground all over an area… Adora felt her stomach drop at the thought. That was…

"Good job," Catra, standing next to her, hissed at Jack, who had the grace to look embarrassed.

"I don't think creating plants that can explode is a good idea," Bow spoke up. "Imagine if those plants spread across a world?"

Adora winced.

"I see," Alpha slowly nodded. "So, that would be an experiment where the scale for requiring approval by authorities would be met since it would potentially endanger an entire world."

"Uh… yes, I think," Entrapta said. "One could do such experiments inside a space lab, of course, so specimens can't spread, but

that’s not perfectly safe - spores might escape anyway. And we know that some plants can survive and grow in space.”

And now everyone was looking at Adora. It wasn’t her fault that her magic had transformed Horde Prime’s flagship into a plant! Well, kind of it was, but she hadn’t known what she was doing. She should have known, of course, but…

“Well,” Daniel spoke up, drawing the attention back to him, “it also depends on which authorities you’re asking for approval. They might not actually have the authority to approve of such experiments.”

“Absent any other representative of the First Ones, Adora and Colonel O’Neill are the legitimate authority with regard to experiments conducted on Research Station Alpha.”

Adora winced again.

“Great. It’s up to us to keep the mad scientists in check,” Jack muttered.

“Yes.” Alpha nodded.

Adora looked at Daniel, but he didn’t look as if he was going to argue this. Nor was any of the others. Not even Glimmer, even though the First Moon of Enchantment belonged to her. Adora glanced at Catra.

Her lover snorted. “Don’t look at me. I don’t know anyone better suited to rein in Entrapta and her friends than you.”

Adora flushed. Well, Catra was terribly biased. Adora wasn’t some… some paragon of wisdom, or something. She didn’t know more about these things than anyone else. Just because she was born a First One didn’t make her qualified for such decisions - especially not about ethics. The First Ones had proven that they weren’t any better than others when they planned to sacrifice Etheria to win the war.

But qualified or not, it was her responsibility - and Jack's - and she would not fail that duty. Straightening, she nodded at Alpha. "Yes." She had to do this. And she would do this.

"So, can we research this?" Entrapta asked. "I mean, the odds of anything exploding are pretty low. And we're not researching plants - not now, at least - but immune system replacements. Perfectly harmless!"

"Unless you create something that replaces the immune system like a symbiont in a Jaffa- and spreads to non-Jaffa," Catra pointed out.

Entrapta blinked, then cocked her head to the side. "Well… that's theoretically possible, I guess. We'd have to create an organism that could replicate outside a lab, perhaps by taking over a host body and using its reproductive system…"

Jack groaned, and Adora closed her eyes.

Why couldn't things be simple - and safe - for once?

*****

Samantha Carter had to agree with Entrapta. She wasn't a biologist or geneticist, but she knew enough about Goa'uld biology to imagine a similar parasite that would permanently alter the host's body to, if not remove, then at least cripple the immune system - like AIDS - and replace it. The trick would be to get it to reproduce inside the host…

She shook her head. They didn't need a plague version of the Goa'uld. Thinking about how to create one was a waste of time. Even if it was an interesting thought experiment. But they had better, more important projects. Much more important projects.

And she wasn't a geneticist. She was a physicist. And a specialist in Ancient technology, though even that would be of limited use here. Probably. But first, she had to remind Entrapta of their priorities. "While we might consider this as a potential threat so

we can plan safeguards and countermeasures, we should focus on our reason for coming here."

"Standard precautions against biological weapons should suffice against such a threat," Alpha commented. "Although I fail to see what use one would get out of such an organism. Unless reproduction is controlled in some way, anyone infected will not be dependent on regular supplies of the symbiont. Therefore, it cannot be used to gain leverage over others. And there are more effective biological weapon systems to reduce an enemy's combat capability."

"Why am I not surprised that the Ancients already thought of the best way to use biological weapons?" the Colonel commented.

Alpha's projection turned to face him. "The logical explanation would be that you are already aware of the research data contained in my data banks."

Sam winced. The Ancients had researched biological weapons here? What was she thinking; of course, they did.

"This day gets better and better," the Colonel muttered.

"This station has biological weapon research data? Samples as well?" Glimmer asked.

"Please answer the question, Alpha," Adora told the A.I. when she didn't reply to the question.

"We have the data for eleven research projects that would qualify as biological weapons, but only seven of them were deemed complete and ready for production, and only five have samples left over from testing. Do you wish me to start producing more samples?"

"Seven weapons? Five samples? What, no, no - don't produce biological weapons!" Adora almost frantically shook her head, and the Colonel had gone quite silent.

"I don't remember seeing this data when we visited the last time," Entrapta said.

"We can produce biological weapons here?" Glimmer looked alarmed as well.

Sam… wasn't really surprised. A species willing to destroy an entire planet to win a war wouldn't baulk at producing and using biological weapons. She only wondered why they were, apparently, not used.

"Were any of them used in the war against Horde Prime?" Anise asked, mirroring Sam's own thoughts.

Once more, Adora had to tell Alpha to answer.

"Yes. Three weapon systems were used in response to invasions by the Horde, but while they were successful in denying the planet to the enemy, the Horde fleet was not significantly affected after the first such attack. Analysis deduced that the Horde's policy of keeping their fleets separate and without contact with each other except for Horde Prime's orders granted them effective resistance even against agents with a long period of incubation, and when the Horde stopped recovering their ground troops after an invasion and started purging affected planets, the research into biological weapons was stopped as not viable."

"Of course, the bastard would just waste his troops like that!" Catra hissed. "If they're written off from the start, they can't infect the rest of a fleet."

"And he was safe from infection himself since he could possess any clone and so didn't need to physically visit. And even if he were infected, he could get a new body," Glimmer added with a grim expression.

Alpha didn't react to their comments, Sam noted.

"So… we probably should look into those projects," Entrapta suggested. "Since they might be aimed at clones, we might need

a cure in case we find the locations where they were used." She looked concerned. "We can't risk our friends like that, can we?"

She was right, Sam realised. The Alliance wasn't using Horde Prime's tactics and policies, and if the fleet got infected with such a weapon… She nodded. "Yes. We need to be prepared for this. If the Goa'uld acquire such weapons, they won't hesitate to use them."

"Yes. Alpha, we need the data - not the samples - for all those weapons," Adora said.

"Of course. Will you limit access to the data to this facility's terminals, or do you wish to download the data?"

"Uh…" Adora glanced at the others. "I think we should limit access to the terminals on this station, yes."

That was probably the best course of action. If such knowledge and data spread… Sam glanced at Anise and Martouf, but they looked taken aback as well.

"You can access them in the archive, then."

"Good." Adora sighed. "We need to check the archives for more research data anyway."

"Yes!" Entrapta smiled.

"Are there any such weapons intended to be used against the Goa'uld?" Anise asked. "Weapons that exclusively target them?"

Which would, therefore, also affect the Tok'ra.

"Please answer the question," the Colonel said, rolling his eyes.

"There are two biological weapons that would be effective against the Goa'uld, but they are effective against all biological organisms. The First Ones did not deem it necessary to develop specific biological weapons against the Goa'uld," Alpha said.

Anise and Martouf looked relieved. Sam was as well. If such a weapon existed, some people in the Alliance would advocate for using it - despite the risk it posed for the Tok'ra. Or, worse, because of the risk.

"Let's go take a look," Entrapta said.

"Yeah…" The Colonel still looked tense. And Daniel looked, well, more than a little disturbed. Like the others here, Sam noted.

Well, she could have also done without hearing those revelations. But as a scientist, she wouldn't shy away from facts no matter how disturbing. Reality didn't change if one tried to ignore it. Reality only changed if you made it change. And you needed facts for that. And science.

*****

"Why is everyone so shocked?" Catra asked as they entered the archives. "Didn't we already find out that the First Ones were not really nice people when we discovered what they had done to the Heart of Etheria?" She saw Adora flinching and clenched her teeth. Adora might be a First One, but she wasn't responsible for their deeds. She had been a baby when she had been taken from them by Hordak and Shadow Weaver.

But Catra should have known better than to bring this up. Even if that wasn't her fault, either.

"Well, in hindsight, maybe this was or should have been obvious," Bow said, grimacing a little. "But I don't think anyone really considered this."

"Ah, I am afraid you're wrong, Bow!" Lance looked up from the terminal he was staring at. "We were already aware of this." His smile looked a little embarrassed.

"You were? And you didn't tell us?" Glimmer frowned at them.

Catra was tempted to make a comment about not feuding with your future father-in-law but held her tongue. That was… a touchy subject. For a variety of reasons Catra wouldn't go into. Not even in her mind.

"We assumed that you knew." George took a step to stand next to Lance and frowned in return at Glimmer. "You had access to this facility for months before we started our project."

"We didn't actually have the time to go through all the data," Glimmer defended herself. "There was so much to organise, and then we left for Earth."

"Well, we had the time - we just focused on other things," Entrapta added. "And I think we all thought that the data about the origin of Etheria - well, of the people of Etheria, or at least of a major part of it - was more important." She cocked her head to the side. "Was that wrong?"

"No," Glimmer told her. "Our origin - the origin of our powers - was more important. We already knew that the First Ones were willing to destroy Etheria to win the war."

Catra grinned. "Which is what I said." She put her arms behind her head and stretched. "We shouldn't be surprised by this. If you're willing to blow up one planet, you're pretty much willing to do anything to win. And the First Ones were ready to destroy many planets," she reminded the others. It wasn't as if the Heart of Etheria would have just killed Horde Prime - or just him and his clones. Horde Prime had been ready to wipe out half the sector, or more, with it.

"Yes. Still, it's one thing to expect something like this and another to find out that there are biological weapons around that," Bow said.

"Yes! We need to ensure that we have an antidote or a cure!" Entrapta said. "And for that, we need the data on those weapons."

Catra nodded. “Yes. Especially if they only affect clones - those weapons could be hiding on populated planets, and we might not notice them since everything would appear fine until the first clone visits.”

Sam nodded. “Yes. We need to prepare countermeasures. And adapt our protocols.”

“Yes, that would be wise,” George said. He still looked slightly disapproving - a bit like Shadow Weaver, Catra couldn’t help thinking.

Glimmer must have been thinking the same thing since she frowned at him in return. “And we’ll require everything you know about those weapons. And your promise that you won’t spread this.”

“Spread it?” Entrapta blinked. “Do you mean you have those samples?”

“I meant spreading the news about this,” Glimmer said. “We don’t need a panic about biological weapons.”

“Of course not!” Lance said. “We’re not irresponsible. We’re historians!”

“Yes.” George was frowning again.

“Looks like there’s some trouble in paradise,” Catra mumbled.

“What?” Adora asked.

Bow cleared his throat before Catra could explain. “Anyway, let’s get to work?” He smiled a little weakly at everyone, but the others nodded.

Catra looked around, then picked one of the comfier-looking seats someone had installed in the room - on Lance and George’s request since they were in the Bright Moon style, not the First

Ones style. That one would do nicely. “Let’s sit down!” she said, then grabbed Adora’s hand.

“But there’s no terminal there,” her love protested.

“Are you a scientist?” Catra asked, raising her eyebrows.

“No!” Adora pouted. “But I took the Horde course for dealing with biological hazards. So did you.”

Catra winced. “That was about dealing with Etherian plants and animals! And monsters!”

“And it included diseases!” Adora nodded firmly and started dragging her to the terminals lined up at the wall.

“But not biological weapons!” Catra protested.

“Close enough! We’re just gathering data, anyway.”

Catra hung her head and did her best to ignore the snickering from Glimmer. It didn’t look like she’d be able to make out with Adora while the others worked. Though, to be fair, this was important work.

And she could still amuse herself by seeing if she could distract her lover if the work turned out too boring.

*****

Jack O’Neill hated alien bioweapons. Well, bioweapons in general. It was one thing to die in combat, shot to death. Or stabbed to death. Or beaten to death, maybe choked to death - Jaffa had a lot of options. But it was another thing to die while your lungs filled with pus or from bleeding sores all over and inside your body. Of course, chemical weapons could have the same effect. And dying from radiation poisoning wasn’t exactly a quick death, either. That stuff was why you tried to save your last bullet for yourself. And sooner or later, they would have to deal with this kind of shit. The Goa’uld would certainly not hold back once they

realised that this was a war to the knife, and Jack was sure that the lab Jakar had destroyed when they met wasn't the only one in the Snake Empire. Not by far.

Although with magical healing, you might not die from such an attack. If someone able to heal was around, and if you were alive enough to make it to that someone. And if you were important enough to get healed, in case a whole world was infected. Jack had his doubts that even Adora could heal an entire world. Even if she would try anyway. But while he hadn't met any other people who could heal with magic, he was pretty sure that they weren't in her league. The Etherians had confirmed that.

And he was also pretty sure that they wouldn't be able to get enough 'healers' from Etheria, by recruiting or training, to make such a difference. Not for the scale the war was going to reach. It wasn't quite going to be the total war World War III would have been, but the mobilisation was already dwarfing Desert Storm levels and was expected to rise a lot more.

That meant Earth needed counteragents. Cures. Maybe even some healing devices, provided they didn't turn you into zombies. And that meant finding out what was hidden in those Ancient databanks. Which boiled down to letting Carter and Entrapta - and probably Bow and Anise, though Jack wasn't so keen on allowing the latter access to this data - do their thing while staying out of their way.

Jack surely had no illusions that he would be of any help just because he had taken a course on dealing with NBC attacks. So he grinned at Catra behind Adora's back and wandered over to where Daniel was chatting with Bow's dads.

"...so you think the Ancients simply left, even though their, ah, experiments were not finished?" Jack heard Daniel ask in a low voice as he approached the three men.

"Yes," Lance replied. "At least, that's what the records we have found and analysed so far tell us."

"If they had left an automated system like Alpha or Light Hope on Etheria to keep an eye on everyone, there should have been some data about it," George added. "Unlike Light Hope, it would have been directly related to this research station, and so it would have needed access to the data here. It wouldn't have made sense to isolate it."

"In my experience, the Ancients had some weird notions about what made sense," Jack cut in with a grin. They certainly had weird experiments. Merging animals and people? Jack suppressed a shudder.

"Well, they had a different culture," Daniel said. "What is considered common sense is often heavily influenced by cultural norms."

"Not letting dangerous stuff lie around and making sure that it won't endanger anyone else seems like a pretty general thing," Jack commented.

But all three men frowned at him. "Jack! Do you know how often that happens on Earth? I mean, doesn't happen as it should?" Daniel shook his head.

"And we have to consider the fact that the First Ones were fighting a war against Horde Prime at the time - a war they were losing," George added. "That will also have influenced their thinking."

"If they were ready to sacrifice Etheria, they would likely not have cared about the experiments on it any more. Or about ensuring that it would be safe." Lance looked grim. "Short of some scientists wanting to save their data for future experiments, maybe."

"Yeah, wars tend to put things into perspective," Jack admitted. "Not always a good thing."

Daniel nodded with a frown. "We have to ensure that we're not falling into the same trap. We can't allow us to justify atrocities in

the hope that it would help us win the war."

His friend must be feeling guilty about the whole 'Goa'uld experimentation' plan, Jack guessed. As if that had been his fault.

Lance and George nodded. "It wouldn't help, anyway - the First Ones tried it, and they still lost," George said. "They might have won, had they had allies instead of…" He scowled. "...'test subjects'."

"Yep. Allies are a good thing. Crucial thing, too," Jack agreed. Provided you could trust them not to stab you in the back.

He looked at the rest of the room, where the others were busy with the bioweapon data search. They could trust the Etherians. At least the bunch of princesses they had met so far - that 'Princess Sweet Bee' didn't sound like someone Jack would trust to watch his back. But what about the next generation?

And what about the Tok'ra?

Well, the priority was to win the war against the Goa'uld. Odds were, whatever problems cropped up afterwards would be political ones, and so none of Jack's business anyway. He didn't have to worry about them.

But sometimes, he couldn't help worrying anyway.

*****

Educational Issues Part 3

Bright Moon, January 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"That was a waste of time!"

Adora rolled her eyes at Catra's outburst. Her lover hadn't stopped complaining since they had returned from the First Moon of Enchantment. And she was wrong. "It wasn't - we learned important information."

"No thanks to us," Catra shot back as she dropped onto their bed. "We just read the stuff Alpha showed us but we didn't understand it."

Adora didn't pout, but she frowned at Catra. That was… not quite right. "We did learn more about the bioweapons the First Ones had."

"And which we now have," Catra said. "And which the Tok'ra and Earth now know about."

Adora pressed her lips together. "We don't have such weapons. Just the data."

"And the samples."

"Those aren't weaponised."

"You just need to fill them into a container and then launch it. A bot could do it."

That was… not wrong. But… "That wouldn't be nearly as effective as a coordinated deployment en masse," Adora said - and then regretted her words at once. 'It could be worse' was never a compelling argument.

Catra snorted. "I bet Entrapta could whip up enough of it - of any of the samples - in a few hours to kill a planet."

Adora didn't disagree. Entrapta was… perfectly able to do that. "But she won't. We talked to her."

Catra shrugged, then rolled on her back. "Whatever. So, what's up until dinner?" She turned her head to grin at Adora and the way she shifted her body left no doubt about what she thought they should do.

And… it wasn't a bad idea. Not at all. The others were already looking into the data they had found, and they couldn't really help with that. And they had an hour or two to kill before dinner.

Adora grinned and slowly walked over to their bed, already loosening her shirt.

*****

Bright Moon, January 19th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, you claim that Earth, despite being a supposed ally of the Princess Alliance, cannot be trusted enough to allow us to travel there through Etheria's Stargate? Really? I've heard more convincing stories from children!" Sweet Bee scoffed and raised her eyebrows.

Adora didn't like the princess. Not at all. She couldn't understand whatever Spinnerella had ever seen in the woman to have a relationship with her, no matter how short - Sweet Bee was all spite and scorn.

But Adora couldn't deny that, laid out like that, their reasons for limiting gate travel sounded a bit weak.

"Earth isn't unified," Glimmer retorted. "As you very well know. And some of their countries consider magic evil."

"And is their Stargate in such a country?"

"Earth's Stargate is under the control of the United Nations of Earth," Glimmer replied.

“You just claimed that Earth wasn’t united.” The lack of surprise on Sweet Bee’s face made it obvious that she knew what the United Nations were. At least in Adora’s opinion. Someone must have told her a lot about Earth.

“The planet isn’t united - the individual countries are basically independent. The United Nations have very little direct power.” Glimmer pressed her lips together.

“But the Stargate isn’t in a country where magic is considered evil, is it? It’s controlled by the Alliance, isn’t it? Effectively, at least.” Sweet Bee smiled, showing her teeth.

“Yes,” Glimmer ground out.

“So, why would anyone be in danger when travelling there?” Sweet Bee asked.

“Every country has dissenters,” Catra pointed out. “And we’re at war.”

“But you can detect our enemies - they cannot hide on a planet. Earth and Etheria are free of those ‘Goa’uld’ and ‘Jaffa’, according to your own claims.”

As much as Adora hated it, Sweet Bee was correct. Sam and Entrapta’s scanner could detect any Jaffa or Go’auld.

“Reasonably safe, yes - according to what we currently know.” Glimmer must be struggling not to grind her teeth.

“And yet, you won’t let us visit the planet. Because you want to force us to fight at your side.” Sweet Bee sneered. “Because you want us under your control. Or, perhaps…” She bared her teeth. “...because you have something to hide? The only ones allowed to travel to Earth are members of the Alliance. Princesses who would never contradict your claims.”

“Are you seriously claiming that we made the whole war up?” Catra scoffed.

"That's one explanation for your attempt to keep us from visiting a supposedly safe planet," Sweet Bee said. "It would explain why you are so adamant about keeping control of the Stargate - and keeping anyone not in your alliance out."

"The other explanation is that we're at war, and the Stargate is a crucial resource for the war, and so it's not going to be used for frilly trips by people too cowardly to fight," Catra retorted.

"Of course, *you* would be saying that.." The princess scowled at Catra. "But we've been watching the Stargate - it's barely in use. It's obvious that it could accommodate much more traffic - at no cost to anyone." She sniffed. "Your story isn't holding up to even basic scrutiny or logic. Just admit that you want to use the Stargate as leverage to control everyone who isn't a member of your alliance!"

"That's a lie!" Glimmer spat.

But Adora couldn't help feeling that Sweet Bee's arguments would look really compelling to people who didn't know better. And if Prince Peekablue, who had been a member of the first Princess Alliance with Glimmer's parents, supported her, many people would believe her claims.

She looked at her friends. Catra was sneering, but Glimmer looked frustrated. And Bow looked as if he felt guilty.

This wasn't a good sign.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 21st, 1999

"...and so we'll have to prepare for a delegation from Etheria led by Princess Sweet Bee to check if Goa'uld are real. Oh, and to check if Earth is safe."

The Colonel didn't even try to hide his annoyance, Samantha Carter noted. She understood it, of course - this news disrupted their already packed schedule. They had much more important work to do than play tour guides. The Stargate would soon be moved, and just organising her lab to be transported without wrecking her projects was a huge amount of work.

"Princess Sweet Bee?" Daniel asked.

"That's her name. I don't know if she's actually part bee, but I wouldn't be surprised. So, you better check your allergies, Daniel, in case she brings alien pollen with her as a snack or something."

Sam sighed - softly - as Daniel pouted. "I don't think she'll bring pollen. Even if she shared some characteristics with bees, bees transport pollen to their hive; it would be illogical for her to transport pollen to Earth."

The Colonel snickered, probably imagining how this would go.

Sam suppressed another sigh. "The Stargate travel protocols will not allow pollen or similar material to spread inside Stargate Command," she pointed out.

"You mean the decontamination and medical drills," the Colonel said.

"Yes."

He snorted, then shrugged. "Anyway, Glimmer's not happy about this, but it seems this was the best the Princess Alliance could do or something."

"As far as I understand, this princess represents kingdoms not aligned with the Princess Alliance," Teal'c commented. "Their military capability is supposed to be negligible, according to Catra."

Sam was surprised that Teal'c had talked to Catra - then realised she shouldn't be. Catra, despite some claims to the contrary, was

quite active in planning the war. And waging it. Like Teal'c, she probably felt that she had to make amends for what she did serving - and leading - the enemy. Not that either of them would admit it, although Sam was sure their reasons for that differed. Still, Sam was curious when they had talked about this. Not curious enough to ask, though.

"Yeah, but, apparently, they can't just ignore the princess." The Colonel shrugged again. "Don't ask me why."

"I assume it's because while the Princess Alliance is the most powerful military power on Etheria, they don't want to act like the Horde," Daniel said. "They might also have economic interests or personal ties to Sweet Bee or her allies that make simply ignoring her request - or demand - impossible. Of course, tradition will also play a role - I assume Etherian culture frowns on ignoring princesses. In an aristocracy, all aristocrats have an interest in ensuring that their status is acknowledged even during disputes and conflicts. Actually, especially during conflicts."

"Yeah, that sounds plausible," the Colonel said.

Daniel started to smile and nod but then caught the Colonel's grin and pouted again.

"So, what are we expected to do?" Sam asked, trying to get the briefing back on track. She didn't ask why SG-1 was tasked with this - they had the most experience in handling such situations, after all. And the Colonel was correct that the sometimes unique biology of Etherians was a potential source of trouble.

"Well, mainly show them around and keep them from getting killed by terrorists, secret agents and traffic," the Colonel replied. "Actually, the generals didn't tell me that explicitly, but we probably should keep them from getting killed, period."

"We're supposed to be bodyguards?" Daniel asked.

"We'll have SG-3 provide actual guards, but keep an eye out as well. While doing your diplomacy thing."

Daniel nodded. “And when will they arrive? Do we have an itinerary? Do we have to prepare one?”

“They’ll visit tomorrow. They didn’t tell us their itinerary - I’m not sure they have one, actually, since they don’t know much about Earth and don’t trust the Princess Alliance.”

“I’ll prepare one, then,” Daniel said.

Sam doubted that the delegation would trust him since SG-1 were known to be friends of Glimmer and the other Princesses in the Alliance, but it wouldn’t hurt. And it might come in useful despite her expectations.

“Good. Also, we’ll have to look into allergies and stuff for Princesses with a ‘special biology’,” the Colonel quoted.

That meant her, Sam knew. “I’ll prepare the scanner and a few potential remedies,” Sam told him.

“You do that.” He smiled at her, and she smiled back for a moment.

Daniel cleared his throat. “So, uh… how many from the Princess Alliance will visit?”

“Everyone we know except for Entrapta is coming as part of the visit,” the Colonel said with a grimace. “So, I guess that means Entrapta drew the short lot and has to stay home to keep the lights on.”

“Ah…” Sam raised her hand. “Entrapta had already scheduled a visit to my lab for tomorrow, sir.”

“I see.” The Colonel frowned - did he think Entrapta being present was a problem? Sam frowned at the thought. That would be unfair. Entrapta was a great friend and meant well; it wasn’t her fault that she sometimes was a bit too enthusiastic. That could happen to any scientist, as Sam could testify.

Daniel blinked. “Uh, Jack… do you mean we have to host the entire leadership of the Princess Alliance and a delegation from another Etherian coalition? Tomorrow?”

The Colonel grinned without much humour. “Yep. It’s going to be fun, I think.”

Sam managed not to glare at him.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, January 22nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“I am looking forward to seeing Earth’s oceans.”

“And to sail on them! Adventure!”

“I am curious about their plants. Their rainforests are said to contain the most fascinating specimens. Though I hope the plants there won’t be as standoffish as cactuses…”

“I doubt that. And even if they are, you’ll win them over, like you did with cactuses!”

“Thank you, Scorpia, but we’re talking about a completely different planet here - the plants might not react well to my magic…”

“I want to visit this ‘Antarctica continent’. It sounds like home.”

Catra shook her head at the conversations she was hearing. “This doesn’t sound like the diplomatic visit they agreed on,” she commented with a smirk to Adora.

Her lover blushed a little. “Well… they’re enthusiastic?”

“They’re treating this like a trip,” Glimmer said in a flat voice.

“Like tourists,” Catra agreed.

“Tourists? Ah, yes.” Adora nodded. “That would fit.”

“What are tourists?” Netossa asked. She was one of the few princesses who didn’t act all giddy about visiting Earth but was focused on their actual task - ensuring that Sweet Bee and her delegation didn’t mess up things for the Alliance.

Of course, Catra suspected that part of the reason for this was that Sweet Bee was the ex of Spinnerella, but as long as it ensured at least one of the bunch of princesses was doing what they were supposed to be doing, she didn’t really care.

Spinnerella, on the other hand, looked a little nervous. Then again, meeting your ex would be awkward. Not that Catra had any personal experience with that. Nor any desire to ever have an ex-girlfriend. She’d die before losing Adora.

“Tourists is an Earth term for people who travel for, ah, leisure. Just to experience another country, take a vacation, that sort of thing,” Bow explained. “I think it comes from ‘tour’, people who go on a tour.”

“Ah.” Netossa nodded. “Like princesses visiting each other?”

“Probably.” Bow shrugged. “But it’s a lot more common on Earth. They have an entire industry based on tourism.”

“Really? That sounds… weird.”

The sound of a skiff approaching drew Catra’s attention away from the discussion. Turning her head, she spotted the vehicle just before it started to descend in front of the gate.

“She almost missed her own trip.” Glimmer scoffed. “Typical.”

“Well, we would have gone without her,” Catra said with a grin. “At least, I don’t think the others would have waited long for her honeyness.”

Glimmer and Bow laughed at that, and Adora snorted, even though she frowned at Catra afterwards.

"What?" Catra grinned. "I'm not going to pretend I like or respect her." And if the princess took offence at that… well, Catra was pretty sure she could take her, should it come to blows. Sweet Bee could fly, but that wouldn't really help her much inside an underground base. Or a similar environment.

"No one likes her," Glimmer complained. "She's just a nagging, entitled princess who didn't have the guts to fight the Horde. But she is a princess, so we have to treat her with some respect."

Catra shrugged. She wouldn't cause a diplomatic incident, but that didn't mean she would be fawning over the twit. Not that it would work, anyway, since Sweet Bee knew what Catra thought of her from their earlier meetings.

"Shh! Here she comes!" Adora whispered. "Oh. She brought Peekablue."

"Ask him to demonstrate his power," Catra whispered.

Adora blinked, then nodded. "Right."

Everyone would have to prove their identity. The last thing they needed was Double Trouble reaching Earth. The traitor would cause chaos just to amuse themselves, no matter how many suffered as a result of it. And if they joined the Goa'uld…

After five minutes of exchanging polite greetings and a not-so-polite discussion about why it was a bad idea to let a shapechanger who thrived on drama loose on an allied planet in the middle of the war, followed by a fairly quick demonstration of everyone's magic powers, they were finally ready to travel to Earth.

While the Stargate was dialling, Catra stepped closer to Glimmer, motioning Adora to join them. "We'll have to hold Alliance meetings off-world for now," she said in a low voice.

"Yes," Glimmer agreed. "If Peekablue can find a scroll I've hidden inside the palace with his seer powers, he can observe our meetings as well. I'll have to ask Castaspella for help with securing the palace against his power, but it might take a while."

"His power could help us a lot in the war, though," Adora pointed out.

"Yes. But he doesn't want to fight anymore." Glimmer shrugged. "Dad said he saw too much while he was with the first Princess Alliance."

"Oh." Adora nodded with a glance at the prince, who was standing a bit apart from them, with Sweet Bee.

Catra scoffed. If the prince couldn't stomach war, he had no business meddling with those who were fighting in it.

Then the gate stabilised, and they got the all-clear from Earth. Catra grinned. Time to find out how Earth would handle the Princesses. And how the princesses would handle Earth.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

Jack O'Neill straightened when the vortex stabilised, and the iris withdrew. "Here they come!" he said. "Put on your best diplomatic smile, and remember: You're not allowed to shoot the nice people with diplomatic immunity no matter how annoying they might get!" he announced.

Carter didn't react, and neither did Teal'c, of course, but Daniel made a sound between a chuckle and a gasp, and Jack thought he caught a soft snort from behind him, where General Hammond, Haig and Petit were waiting. Probably Petit - Hammond was used to Jack's jokes, and Haig never showed any emotion. And the weenies from the State Department looked as if

he had just mooned them. They didn't try to scold him, though, so they must have been briefed competently.

He was joking, of course, but only just. It would have been bad enough to meet Princess Sweet Bee and Prince Peekablue, but they were also going to meet pretty much every other princess in the Princess Alliance. They were, effectively, hosting something like the G20 in Stargate Command. On two days' notice.

Jack didn't believe the rumours that the Secretary of State had offered to resign upon being informed of this - that was probably spread by someone angling for the man's job - but the diplomats Washington had sent were certainly nervous enough to make everyone else nervous. Well, everyone not used to the Etherians. And, of course, there was the general shift of priorities in Washington.

"Wouldn't even want to know how bad things would be if we weren't at war," he muttered under his breath. Organising such a visit would have taken months and countless meetings in peacetime.

"Sir?" Carter asked from next to him.

"Nothing. Just musing that the good old 'wartime expediency' thing is working out in our favour for once."

"Ah."

"What do you mean?" Daniel asked.

Fortunately, Jack was spared from explaining just how much worse things could have been by their first visitors stepping through the gate. Adora, followed by Catra.

Followed by a bunch of enthusiastic young people with magic powers looking around as if they were just entering Disneyland for the first time. And an older couple that was trying to appear bored while still looking around as if they were first-time visitors to Disneyland as well.

Those two would be Sweet Bee and Peekablue, then. Sweet Bee actually had wings on her back - far too small to let her fly, if not for magic. And Peekablue was… blue. And kind of… what did Daniel call it? Androgynous? David Bowie-ish in the seventies was what Jack would call it. He pushed the thought away and focused on Netossa and Spinnerella, who were bringing up the rear and looking around unabashedly.

"Hi, Jack!" Adora greeted him. "Hi, Sam, Daniel, Teal'c!"

"Jack." Catra nodded at him and the rest of his team.

"Hello, everyone!" Scorpia beamed.

"Hi, Jack. Sam. Daniel. Teal'c." Glimmer nodded at everyone in turn.

"Sam!" Entrapta headed straight to Carter. "I've got the new designs for our projects. Take a look!"

"Oh, we're underground… Hi, everyone!" Perfuma looked around, waving.

"Hello, everyone." Frosta was trying to act as regal as Glimmer but not quite pulling it off.

Jack noticed the stare from the diplomats. They had been briefed, but meeting the real thing was still a shock, it seemed. Had they expected a group of Queen Elizabeths, all stern and stiff upper lip? Well, time to get this show on the road. He stepped forward and started introducing everyone to everyone.

Which took a while.

*****

"And this is the Gate Control Room," General Hammond explained as they entered it. "This houses the computers controlling the gate."

Jack resisted the urge to make a joke about 'Carter's kingdom. Touch them at your own peril'. She had gone to her lab with Entrapta, so it would have been wasted anyway.

"Oh, nice. Do you have gun emplacements as well? You've got a good field of fire from here." Netossa asked.

"Ah, no," Hammond said.

"But the new gate room we're constructing in Canada will have them," Jack cut in. He had seen the plans, after all. Before and after Carter and Entrapta had gone over them.

"Ah. What type? We've got some Horde Sentry guns back home, but they're not very impressive. Basically immobile bots."

"Heavy machine guns and anti-tank missiles," Jack informed her.

"Pure Earth technology?" Netossa asked, cocking her head.

"Yes. It should be effective enough," Jack confirmed. He was the one who had been pushing for anti-tank missiles, just in case - the Stargate was big enough for a combat vehicle to pass through, after all.

"Stargate Command is operated by forces detached to the United Nations, and so is not allowed to operate equipment restricted to Alliance forces," General Haig explained.

"What about Captain Carter's lab?" Spinerella asked.

"That's a special case," Haig said.

A very special case Jack really didn't want to explain in detail. Mostly because they still hadn't sorted out what pieces of tech belonged to Stargate Command, what belonged to the United States, and what were Alliance property. Jack would have transferred everything out, but Stargate Command needed some advanced technology, for security purposes at least.

“So, you don’t trust each other with your technology,” Sweet Bee commented.

“We don’t share technology outside the Alliance,” Glimmer retorted with a toothy smile. “Here or on Etheria - as you already knew.”

The other princess sniffed. “If Earth technology can keep a Stargate safe, then evidently, the danger is not as great as you made it out to be.”

“Earth military technology is quite effective in ground combat,” Adora pointed out. “It’s roughly on par with Horde technology during the war on Etheria.”

“And yet they need our help? It must be a profitable arrangement, I guess.” Sweet Bee was, obviously, not going to be easily swayed. Or at all. She would fit in great with a number of politicians Jack could think of.

But he was used to those kinds of people. That Sweet Bee was a bit younger and better looking than the usual type on Earth - and had wings - didn’t make much of a difference as far as he was concerned. They could handle her.

Now Peekablue, on the other hand… He hadn’t said much and kept staring at nothing in particular, and Jack had a feeling that it wasn’t because the man was stoned out of his mind. Glimmer had mentioned that he had ‘the power of far sight’, and Jack was wondering - and worried - just how far that sight could reach.

*****

“...and that’s about everything here in Stargate Command. I hope you enjoyed your tour.”

Adora heard Netossa snicker softly at Jack’s comment. Her friend probably thought that Jack was subtly joking about them being tourists. Which could totally be true, of course. But Adora couldn’t tell for sure.

“We haven’t seen everything,” Sweet Bee complained. She shared a glance with Peekablue, Adora noticed. “Not even most of it.”

“Yep.” Jack smiled sweetly at the princess. “The rest of the base is off-limits for visitors. For security reasons - can’t have people stumble into delicate experiments. Or disturb the sick, you know.”

“There are no sick people inside this area of the base,” Peekablue spoke up, tilting his head back. “And the number of sick people in the areas above us is also quite small.”

Jack’s smile grew a little toothy. “The area above us isn’t part of Stargate Command. That’s a normal military base.”

One of the most important military bases, as far as Adora knew. But not part of Stargate Command, yes.

“You seriously claim that it isn’t the same base?” Sweet Bee scoffed. “We’re in the same location - just further below them. We can take a lift to their part of the base. What are you trying to hide with this cheap attempt at sophistry?”

Adora frowned. It was very rude to accuse your hosts of lying to you.

“Stargate Command shares some infrastructure with the Cheyenne Mountain Complex, but we’re under United Nations Command,” General Hammond replied. “And the base is off-limits to Air Force personnel not assigned to the United Nations, just as Stargate Command forces aren’t allowed into the Air Force base above us.”

“Can’t let the Russians and Chinese take a peek at our aerospace defence,” Jack added.

Oh! Adora was sure that this was a deliberate dig at Peekablue - though the prince had made it obvious that he was using his power to peek... to spy on the people here. Which was rude. And which Adora should have said something about. But that might have led to a diplomatic incident and been just what Sweet Bee

wanted so she could claim that the Alliance was trying to oppress everyone else.

But now she was claiming that they were hiding things from them. Well, they were - but those were things that Sweet Bee had no right to see.

"A likely excuse!" Sweet Bee scoffed again.

Catra snorted loudly. "You've got a lot of nerve. You spy on the American base above us, then complain that they don't want to show it to you? You should be glad that Stargate Command hasn't thrown you out for that!" She turned to smile at General Hammond. "Which would be totally understandable, by the way."

Adora clenched her teeth. Catra wasn't wrong, not really, but… this was rude as well. Although… Glimmer wasn't saying anything.

Jack chuckled, but the general merely nodded. "That's a political decision."

Everyone looked at the diplomats with the group. They didn't look like they enjoyed being put on the spot like this, in Adora's opinion.

"I am sure this can be solved amiably," their apparent leader, Mister Clark, said with a fake smile. "We are aware that Etherian customs differ from ours and that it is considered rude to prohibit the use of magic power."

"Using your power to spy on others is also considered rude," Glimmer informed him.

"We are here to find out if your claims about the war, Earth and the Goa'uld are true," Peekablue retorted, looking straight at Glimmer. "That was understood from the start. Merely following a prepared tour to show us what you and your allies want us to see and nothing else would have been pointless and against both the letter and spirit of our agreement."

That was… not wrong, either, Adora had to admit. It was still rude, though.

"And I am sure your allies here understood that as well," Sweet Bee added.

"It was a consideration when debating whether or not we would agree to this visit," Clark said. His smile had grown even thinner.

"And you did agree." Swee Bee nodded.

"And you knew that some areas would be off-limits as well," Jack pointed out. "That's how the military works."

"Not that *you* would know anything about that," Glimmer added with a sneer aimed at Sweet Bee.

"But I would." Peekablue narrowed his eyes at her.

"Then you should act like it," Glimmer told him with a glare.

"I am." He nodded. "While mildly interesting, touring this base does not answer our questions. We need to meet those Goa'uld - and see more of your planet."

"Yes!" Perfuma nodded, then blushed. "I mean… a planet is far more than just a base. Underground."

Adora could see that everyone else from their friends - everyone who was visiting Earth for the first time - agreed. As she had expected.

General Hammond exchanged glances with General Haig and General Petit. "Our Goa'uld prisoners are kept in another location - it has been deemed too dangerous to keep them close to the Stargate. But we can shuttle you to their prison, or you can meet with members of the Tok'ra, although they won't arrive for some time. Of course, should you want to meet the Goa'uld, then, for everyone's safety, we have to insist on physical separation."

“We’re aware of their power,” Peekablue told him.

“At least of what you claim their power is,” Sweet Bee added with a slight sneer.

“We should let a Tok’ra take over her body,” Catra whispered.

Adora pressed her lips together. That would… the Tok’ra didn’t take over people against their will. And it might be dangerous - they didn’t know how magic would react to Goa’uld. And it would be wrong, of course.

But it would be a funny way to shut the princess up. Adora was really tired of hearing Sweet Bee’s sniping remarks and not-so-veiled accusations.

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“...and so, this data shows how the First Ones combined different species into a new one with parts of both. It’s really tricky, by the way - even the First Ones had a lot of failures with the more challenging experiments.”

Samantha Carter managed not to wince at the data she was shown. ‘Failures’ meant not just non-viable results but also people who lived just long enough to die painfully. And people who lived long enough to die slowly and painfully. “Do the others know about this?” she asked.

Entrapta blinked. “I think so - they got the same data we got, didn’t they? At least, they have access to the same data. But I would have to check with Glimmer. Or Adora - she’s the one Alpha listens to when we need permissions. And Jack, but he’s usually not on Etheria.”

Sam doubted that the other princesses had analysed the data. Adora would have been shocked at what her ancestors had done and feeling guilty - even though she was absolutely blameless.

"Do you think they will help us? Some of the experiments require magic we don't have access to yet, though I think unless it's an experiment with plants, we should probably ask Castaspella. Or Adora, but she needs the boost to her power from returning magic to a world, and she said she needs better control as well, so that might not be a viable method yet."

"I doubt that they would want to duplicate the experiments of the First Ones," Sam said as gently as she could.

"Well, of course not!" Entrapata nodded firmly, and Sam was just starting to wonder if her friend was aware of the issues when she continued: "We already know how those were done and what results they had. We need new experiments to find a solution to the Jaffa's lack of an immune system."

That wasn't Sam's point, but she nodded anyway. "Yes. But I don't think creating a new species out of Jaffa is the answer. That won't help the Jaffa."

"Yes." Entrapta turned towards the big screen in Sam's lab. "But once we have a viable template, we could use that as a model for altering the Jaffa's bodies."

Gene therapy on that level… Before she had found out about the Ancients and their technology, Sam would have dismissed that as unrealistic science fiction. Or fantasy. But given what they knew now… "That might work, but there might be easier and quicker solutions. Like a symbiotic organism that could also help humans with immunodeficiency. It would certainly be easier to get funding for such a project than for a project to save aliens who were, for the most part, fighting for the Goa'uld."

"That's true. But we can still use this data to see how we might be able to change existing symbionts. Not sapient ones, of course!" Etheria nodded twice. "But if we can change the intestinal bacteria, that would be a great first step. And the final result should be easy to implement - the better bacteria will replace the weaker ones organically."

“It will require extensive testing, though,” Sam pointed out. If they created an invasive bacteria that replaced the gut flora in humans and turned out to be harmful or have harmful side effects… that would be a horrible bioweapon. And one manufactured by themselves.

“Yes!” Entrapta beamed. “It should be fun. We might be able to improve the digestive system as well - imagine if we could eat grass, like cows! That would probably solve some of the problems on Earth with food distribution.” She frowned. “I still don’t understand why you can’t just ensure that everyone gets enough food. You’ve had so long to figure out things, and you have the production and transport capacity according to the data from your logisticians.”

Sam winced. “It’s a complex situation,” she said.

“Why is it complex? People are starving, and others have a surplus of food - according to the fitness reports from the Alliance, you have overweight soldiers. So, the obvious solution is to move food from those who have too much to those who don’t have enough.” Entrapta shook her head. “Everybody would win that way.”

If the Colonel were here, he would make a joke about communist princesses. But he wasn’t here - he was dealing with the rest of the visitors from Etheria. He, Daniel and Teal’c. So, it fell to Sam to explain why things were not as simple as they seemed. “It’s not just a question of food distribution, but also of politics and business processes. Most ‘simple solutions’ to similar problems tended to cause more serious problems later.”

“More serious problems than people starving?” Entrapta asked.

“Sometimes, more people ended up starving,” Sam told her. “Like when food aid caused local food production to become unprofitable.”

Once more, her friend frowned. “But… that would only happen if you distributed too much food, wouldn’t it?”

Sam sighed. “Not quite. Often, expectations are enough to change how people act - or what they sow. If a farmer expects to get more money producing a cash crop instead of food, then they’ll switch production.”

“Ah. But isn’t the system you use meant to react to that by making food more expensive so people will produce more food?”

Sam pressed her lips together and decided that she would have to have a talk with Daniel about going into more detail when he was teaching people about Earth’s economy. “In theory, yes, but it’s not as simple as it sounds since humans don’t always make perfectly rational decisions - and even if they did, sometimes, the most profitable decision for an individual is not the best for everyone else.”

“That sounds like a flaw of the system,” Entrapta said.

“Yes. But we haven’t found a better system yet.”

“That does sound complicated.” Entrapta shook her head. “You better find a solution - if you have to keep patching up a broken system, it ends up more work, far more work, than designing a better system from the ground up.”

Sam was forced to agree. But this wasn’t what they were here for. “Although since neither of us is an economist, we should probably stick to what we can do.”

Entrapta nodded. “Yes! Back to Project Smybiont Mark Two!”

Sam sighed with relief. And a bit of shame.

*****

“So… after the prison visit, you want to visit Antarctica, the rainforest in the Amazon basin, New York, Brussels, Switzerland,

Disney World, Hawaii, the Vatican and Mecca?”

O’Neill hadn’t managed to keep his unfazed facade going, Catra noted, when the princesses had started to answer his question of where they wanted to go after the visit to the Goa’uld’s prison. He really should have expected this.

“Yes.” Frosta nodded with that overly serious expression of hers that made her look even younger. Catra was glad that she had never tried to look ‘mature’. “The shuttle should be able to reach any spot on the planet in less than an hour, right?” She nodded at the shuttle standing behind O’Neill on the landing pad.

“Yes - the shuttle’s rated for that speed, though we’ll have to go orbital for some trips, I think,” Scorpia said before O’Neill - or Daniel, who had already opened his mouth - could react. She would have read up on the shuttles’ specs before the attack on Heru’ur’s base, of course. “But that will cut down on the time we can actually spend at every location.”

“That would run the point of the visit,” Perfuma complained. “Maybe we could split up?”

O’Neill’s expression clearly showed what he thought of that proposal.

But the other princesses nodded. “I don’t want to see a jungle,” Frosta said.

“As long as I can visit the sea, I’m fine. Though I would prefer an ocean that’s not covered in ice,” Mermista added.

“But we should all visit Disney World together,” Perfuma added. “It looks far more fun with friends.”

“We can’t visit Disney World,” O’Neill said. “Security reasons,” he added with a stern glare. “We would have to shut down the park for your visit, and that would mean shoving thousands of people out for you.”

“Oh, no!” Perfuma gasped. “We can’t do that - this would be incredibly selfish! And a deserted Disney World doesn’t sound like it would be fun, anyway.”

“Why would you have to do that?” Sweet Bee asked with narrowed eyes. “Do you want to keep us from talking or even seeing your people?”

“As I told you: security reasons.” O’Neill met her eyes.

“A likely answer.” Sweet Bee scoffed.

Catra rolled her eyes. “The chance that some dangerous nutcase will attack us is too high,” she said. “You arrogant moron,” she added under her breath, which earned her a hissed ‘Catra!’ from Adora.

“A convenient excuse,” Sweet Bee shot back. “But you can’t keep us from finding out the truth! I assume you’ll claim that visiting the Vatican and Mecca is also ‘too dangerous’?”

“The Vatican is a sovereign state. Whether or not you can visit the Pope is up to him,” O’Neill said. “Mecca is off-limits, though, unless you’re a Muslim.”

Sweet Bee huffed. “How is their leader supposed to meet with guests, then? Do they have a palace outside their kingdom?”

“I am sure King Fahd of Saudi Arabia has palaces access the world - or can buy one on short notice,” O’Neill said with a grin.

Daniel cleared his throat. “I think there’s been a misunderstanding,” he said. “You want to visit the Vatican and Mecca because you want information about the two biggest religions on Earth, right?”

“And the two most hostile according to you, yes.” Sweet Bee nodded. “Speaking to their leaders is the obvious course of action if we want to test this.”

“Well, both Christianity and Islam are actually made up of many factions and sects, without an overall leader. The Pope might come closest, but he doesn’t represent all or even a clear majority of Christians, only the Catholics. There is no such leader for the Muslim world, though,” Daniel explained. “You would be better served to talk to several experts and prominent theologists.”

“Which you would carefully choose,” Sweet Bee retorted. “We prefer to make our own judgement.”

“But your information about Earth is clearly incomplete,” Adora told her. “Did you know that magic is illegal in Saudi Arabia?”

“Or that just meeting with you might be enough for the King of Saudi Arabia to be toppled by his family? Or a revolution?” Glimmer scoffed.

“My sources assured me that their information was correct.” Sweet Bee glared at her. “And you admitted to hiding information from us!”

“Sounds like exaggerated rumours,” Catra said, shaking her head. “Probably something overheard in the Palace by a guard or servant, and then it spread. Unless you let people watch Earth television.” She hadn’t heard of anything like that, but soldiers always traded and smuggled contraband. Though the timing was off for this to have come from the intervention, and before that, contact with Earth had been limited to their group. Probably rumours, then.

“We didn’t import any TVs,” Bow said.

“My sources prefer to remain anonymous,” Sweet Bee said. “They fear your reaction to revealing your propaganda.”

“Or they have peeked at us from afar and didn’t quite understand what they saw:” Catra stared at Peekablue. “Did you spy on us watching TV?”

Peekablue had a great poker face and didn't react, but Sweet Bee scowled even more, and Catra was sure that her guess was correct.

"You've been spying on us!" Glimmer spat.

"That's a slanderous accusation without any proof!" Sweet Bee shot back.

She didn't deny it, Catra noted.

"Well, I think we can swing a meeting with the Pope, but Mecca - and Saudi Arabia in general - are off the table," O'Neill said. "Antarctica, though, we can easily do. And I think we can also find a nice safe patch of rainforest in Hawaii."

Catra narrowed her eyes. All those would be safe locations - and under Alliance control.

"I want to talk to other leaders of Earth!" Sweet Bee insisted. "I do not trust your carefully chosen spots to provide us with the information we need!" She stared at O'Neill and crossed her arms over her chest.

"And we won't let you make deals with potentially hostile countries," Glimmer shot back.

"Hah! You show your true colours!" Sweet Bee sneered. "We're sovereign rulers of our own kingdoms! We are not beholden to you!"

And the two started bickering. "Maybe we should let them visit Mecca," Catra whispered to Adora.

"Catra!" Adora shook her head. "But they're right - we can't just keep them from seeing more of Earth if we want this trip to settle their claims."

Catra doubted that Sweet Bee would accept the truth even if it hit her in the face - literally, in some cases - but Adora was right.

They had to make an effort to at least give the morons enough rope to hang themselves.

But how to arrange that?

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Educational Issues Part 4

Thule Air Force Base, Greenland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

There wasn't much positive about visiting the United States' northernmost base. Thule Air Force Base was located in northern Greenland, on the west coast of the island, in the middle of ice and snow and frozen seas. The closest village was dozens of miles away. Most airmen considered being posted there as a punishment.

Jack O'Neill didn't know who had chosen the location to house their Goa'uld prisoners, but it must have been someone really, really concerned about a snake escaping from prison and hiding amongst the population. Of course, Jack couldn't fault them for being cautious, but still… a glance at the landscape made him have flashbacks to the cave in Antarctica where he and Carter had almost frozen to death.

"At least we can scratch Antarctica from the itinerary for the rest of the visit," he muttered as they stepped out of the shuttle and into the new shuttle hangar they had built with the new prison section here. "This should be close enough for Frosta."

"What did you say, Jack?" Daniel asked as he pulled on the cowl of his jacket, even though they were inside a hangar and not on the airstrip outside. Then again, it was still damn cold - they were just closing the doors again.

"Nothing." Jack gritted his teeth, then raised his voice. "Welcome to Thule Air Force Base! Now our newest prison camp!"

"This is horrible! How can people live here?"

"I can't feel any plants around - except for some lichens, and they are always weird."

"I think housing prisoners here is violating their rights."

“Their rights? What about our rights! We have to visit them here!”

“Catra!”

“This is a transparent attempt to discourage us from talking to the population! That you were going as far as to move helpless prisoners to such a location is a disgrace! And why aren’t you magically heating this place up?”

“Frosta! What are you doing?”

“This is great! It feels like home!”

Jack turned away from smiling overly sweetly at the Bee Princess and spotted Frosta walking straight to the shrinking opening of the hangar doors, arms spread and beaming as if Disneyland was outside. Obviously, Greenland in the middle of winter was close enough to her own kingdom.

And, equally obvious, the cold wasn’t bothering her - she skipped outside just before the doors closed.

“Hey! Wait!”

“Someone get her before she freezes!”

Oh. Some of the airmen stationed here must not have read the briefing about their visitors. Jack raised his arm and stopped them from opening the doors again. “Don’t worry about her - she controls the cold.”

“What? Sir!” They belatedly saluted him.

“Frosta will be fine,” Glimmer told them. “Ice is her element.” She was shivering a little, Jack noted.

“Would be great if she could control the cold instead of the ice,” Catra commented.

“That’s not how elemental powers work,” Glimmer shot back.

“I know. But that’s how they should work.” Catra grinned.

With the doors closed, it was getting warmer - the curtain of hot air that was supposed to keep the cold out when the doors were open wasn’t working as well as it should, in Jack’s opinion. This was a hangar in Greenland, not a mall in New York. Maybe he should ask Carter for a better system, in case they had to visit this base again… No, that would be irresponsible. And Carter would tell him so.

The airmen looked sceptical. One of them peered through the small windows in the hangar door, then recoiled. “Holy shit! She’s surfing on ice - on ice waves!”

“What?”

Of course, now everyone had to take a look. Jack sighed and clapped his hands together. “So, while Miss Ice Princess is playing with the snow outside, how about we go and visit the snakes held here? The sooner we start, the sooner we’re done and can leave for somewhere warmer!”

“Yeah! Let’s do this!” Catra agreed. Her tail was twitching.

“We really should have taken our spacesuits,” Bow said.

“Not everyone has a spacesuit,” Mermista pointed out.

“What? You should have said something. Entrapta made suits for everyone. Well, everyone in the Alliance,” Scorpia said.

“Well, she never told us. And how would she have gotten our measurements?” Mermista asked.

“Ah… we had your measurements in our database.” Scorpia scratched the back of her head, and her stinger twitched. “Apparently, Double Trouble is really thorough when preparing to impersonate someone.”

“You have our measurements?”

“What? When did they take them?”

“I don’t know.”

“We need better information security. No Horde spy should have gotten that intel.”

“Double Trouble wasn’t a Horde Spy but in it for themselves,” Catra retorted.

“No other spies should have gotten this information either.”

Jack pressed his lips together so he wouldn’t make a joke about their weight to the airmen. At least, most of the men were now staring at the princesses inside the hangar and not crowding the small window to the outside.

“What the… the airstrip is now covered in frozen waves of ice!”

Jack had spoken too soon. “Don’t worry, she’ll clean that up,” he told the men.

He hoped he wasn’t wrong. If they had to clean up that maze of ice waves and ramps by themselves… Jack was really glad shuttles didn’t need an airstrip and could take off vertically, or they would be stuck here for a while. Oh.

Bending down, he whispered: “Someone needs to tell Frosta to clean the airstrip once she’s done. Before Her Honeyness thinks this is a plot to keep them here.”

Glimmer sighed as she nodded.

“I’m really sorry,” Adora added with a grimace.

Catra scoffed. “Whatever. Let’s go talk to the snakes.”

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This base was… well, Adora couldn’t say it was horrible. It was built nicely - at least the part they were visiting. That one was

brand-new. She didn't see any sign of the wear and tear you got after a garrison had been quartered there for a few years. No odd smells, either. And it looked quite comfortable - Stargate Command style, not Hordak's Horde style. Or Horde Prime's.

But it was located at what Jack called the end of the world, as close to the North Pole as it could get, or so she had heard. And it had been in use for decades, as part of their early warning system or something, in the Cold War between the United States and Russia. To be stuck here for months or years… She shuddered. She would wish that on no one. Well, maybe on Frosta - the princess apparently loved it here, from what Adora had seen before that had left the hangar. The outside had been covered in ice structures by then.

"This is a new prison. You built a special prison for your enemies?" Sweet Bee asked.

"Yes. Our normal prisons were not really set up for Goa'uld," Jack told her.

"You treat them like a princess," Peekablue added before his eyes lost focus - he was using his magic again.

"Well, you could say that!" Jack laughed, then blinked and seemed surprised.

Adora didn't quite understand what he found funny - you had to take special precautions when dealing with captured princesses. They had taught that to every Horde soldier. And the Alliance knew that as well - it was obvious, after all.

Catra snorted at Jack - Adora would have to ask her what was funny. After this, though - they had just reached another checkpoint with a closed door. A closed airlock, if that was the same type as the one they had gone through at the top.

It was. And there were lots of sensors that Adora could spot - probably Sam and Entrapta's work.

“Even if the Goa’uld managed to escape, we could find them with the scanner,” Catra commented as they stepped through the airlock. “There was no need to move them to the end of the world.”

“But if they escaped in a more populated area, they could do a lot of damage and hurt a lot of people before we could recapture them,” Bow pointed out.

“They could have found a warmer place, at least,” Catra retorted.

“Well, apparently, someone thought the cold would be an added deterrent against the Goa’uld.” Jack shrugged. “They probably didn’t get that they aren’t actual reptiles which would be bothered by the cold.”

“I think everyone would be bothered by the cold here,” Glimmer said.

“Except for our snow princess,” Catra added with another snort. “I’d say she has ice water for blood, but she’s too hotheaded for that.”

Adora frowned at her. You didn’t talk about your friends like that. She knew better than to say anything, though - Catra would make a remark about not being friends with Frosta. And vice versa. Well, that might change. Someday.

“Good security in any case,” Netossa said, nodding appreciatively.

“It certainly emphasises how worried you are about your prisoners,” Sweet Bee… kinda agreed? But she was smiling in a slightly mocking way, Adora noticed. Another barb, then. Or an insinuation.

Adora was really tired of this kind of talk. It reminded her a bit too much of how Shadow Weaver had liked to twist words.

“That’s because we are,” Jack told her. “They can take over your body, turning you into a prisoner in your own mind.”

Spinnerella shuddered, and Adora saw Netossa hug her.

She glanced at Catra, but her lover didn't show any reaction at the - probably accidental - reminder of how Horde Prime had controlled her. She was remembering it, though - Adora knew that.

She grabbed Catra's hand to gently squeeze it and frowned at Jack, but he was already approaching the next, and hopefully last checkpoint before the actual cell area.

Five minutes later - and one comment from Catra about the time it would take if they had to reach the prisoners in a hurry, and another from Glimmer about how she would be able to bypass all checkpoints, which left Jack grimacing and the guards staring - they were finally in front of the cells - or habitats - of Seth and Osiris. And a few more behind them - the place was set up to hold a lot of them, Adora realised. Well, that was just thinking ahead.

"Hello!" she said, waving at the transparent windows.

"So, these are Goa'uld?" Sweet Bee leaned forward to peer at the two prisoners, who seemed to ignore her. "Are they well?"

They looked, well, healthy, as far as Adora could tell, and the habitats looked nice, but she had expected them to react at once to their arrival, and the two Goa'uld didn't do that. Were they affected this badly by the lack of a sapient host? That would be… a big problem. They couldn't provide them with hosts, that would be cruel to the hosts, but leaving them like this would also be cruel.

Catra, though, scoffed. "They're just playing for sympathy."

"Yeah. Don't let them fool you," Jack added.

"Of course, you'd say that." Sweet Bee sniffed. "Can they hear us?"

If they couldn’t, Adora would have looked very foolish for talking to them.

“Yes. They just don’t want to talk, it seems.” Jack shrugged.

But then Seth moved towards the tiny keyboard in his cell, and as soon as he had started moving, Osiris moved to his own. Both typed quickly, and synthetic voices rang out simultaneously.

“Greetings.” “I greet you, visitors.”

Adora expected them to glare at each other, but they kept talking - at the same time.

“You aren’t Tau’ri.” “What brings you to my humble abode?”

“Please, don’t talk at the same time; it’s hard to understand you,” Adora said, raising her hand.

“Yes. Stay silent while your betters talk!” Seth told Osiris.

“Why would they talk to a traitorous piece of filth like you? You have proven time and again that you cannot be trusted!”

“You, who tried to usurp Ra’s power with your wife, accuse me of being a traitor?”

“I did not spend thousands of years amongst the Tau’ri, founding cults and then enticing my followers into suicide once I grew tired of them.”

“You didn’t because you were imprisoned for your betrayal.”

“A betrayal you set up - only to double-cross us! Only a fool would trust a single word of yours after this!”

“You would have betrayed me in a heartbeat, brother!”

“No! I trusted you!”

“Trusted me to be betrayed! You think I wasn’t aware that you were willing to stab me in the back on your wife’s orders?”

Adora saw Jack push a few buttons on the keyboard on the wall next to the cells, and the synthetic voices of the two Goa’uld grew dimmer.

“I’ve also muted us. I am kind of curious how long it will take them to notice,” he told them with a grin.

“They are brothers?” Sweet Bee asked.

“Yep. That’s your typical wholesome Goa’uld family. Backstabbing, bickering and bitching all day long.”

Sweet Bee eyed the two Goa’uld. “They are thousands of years old?”

“Yep.”

“Yet, they bicker like children.” She shook her head.

“Don’t be fooled by their antics - they have oppressed and murdered countless people,” Daniel cut in. “You cannot underestimate them.”

“They loathe each other, yet you have placed them in cells next to each other?” Sweet Bee shook her head. “That seems cruel.”

“Well… isolating them would be cruel as well.” Jack shrugged. “Can’t win here. And they can mute each other and turn the cell windows opaque, so it’s not as if they’re forced to talk or even see each other.”

“And they might let slip important information while they bicker,” Peekablue said.

Jack nodded, and his grin widened a bit. “Mostly historical information - they have been stuck on Earth one way or the other

for the last few thousand years - but it helps piecing together how the snakes think."

"The Goa'uld rulers have been in power for a very long time," Daniel added. "And as you can see, they carry grudges."

Sweet Bee frowned, but Adora couldn't tell if she was annoyed at the Goa'uld, Adora and her friends, or herself. "We still want to talk to them."

"Be our guest," Jack told her, spreading his hands. "Once they stop bickering, they will probably be ready to talk. But I'd suggest talking to each one separately."

"Of course." Sweet Bee scoffed. "It's clear that they cannot stand each other, so trying to talk to them together would not serve our needs. Now, who is the higher-ranked?"

"Higher-ranked?" Jack blinked.

"It would be a fauxpas if we talked to the lower ranked of the two first," Sweet Bee explained.

"And that would be inconceivable, right?" Jack asked.

His sarcasm was quite obvious, and Sweet Bee glared at him. "The proper forms have to be observed. Especially if you have someone at your mercy. How could you trust someone who only shows respect when forced to?"

Jack narrowed his eyes at the princess, but Adora couldn't help but agree - a bit, at least. And many of her friends seemed to agree as well.

"We don't really follow the whole 'nobles are better than peasants' on Earth. Everyone's equal," Jack told Sweet Bee.

Sweet Bee scoffed in return. "That you elect your leaders does not change the fact that you have leaders who command and others who follow. Like you have officers leading soldiers."

"Uh, that's not exactly the point," Daniel spoke up. "In those cases, it's about the position - tied to the position."

"And their current position is 'prisoners'," Jack said.

"And yet, they were rulers both. That demands respect," Sweet Bee retorted.

"Respect has to be earned," Jack shot back.

"And they were toppled by their own," Catra added with a shrug. "They weren't princesses when we captured them but fugitives. Osiris technically was a prisoner already."

"That doesn't mean they shouldn't be treated without respect," Sweet Bee spat with a glare.

"We do that," Adora spoke up. "They are people, like us. And we do our best to treat them in a respectful manner." She was pretty sure they did, and the United States would know better than to abuse prisoners, but she might have to check that after this.

"We are not going to treat them like the gods they claim to be. They are false gods." Teal'c inclined his head.

"Yeah. We're not going to worship them and stuff," Jack said, showing his teeth in a grin. "But feel free to do so if you want."

Sweet Bee scoffed once more. "I shall address them as fits a captured leader. But, again: Who amongst them is the higher-ranked?"

"Uh…" Daniel grimaced. "That's actually a good question. Osiris's power seemed to have been tied to Isis as much or more than to his own achievements, but he was the first Pharaoh, or so our sources claim, while we are a bit at a loss about the exact status of Seth - he was subordinate to Ra, that much we know, but whether he was of a higher rank than Osiris remains in doubt." He cocked his head. "I don't think we actually looked into this, and I

think we should since it might grant us more insight into Goa'uld society."

Sweet Bee blinked. "So, you don't know."

"Yes." Daniel smiled at her.

Catra snickered, and Adora had to suppress a chuckle herself at the way Sweet Bee flushed with annoyance.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"...and so, the bacteria have an effect on the immune system, but it's an indirect effect. We need a more direct effect. Although if we supplemented the immune system through that method and then increased that effect, we might be able to replace a non-functional immune system."

Samantha Carter nodded - Entrapta's reasoning seemed sound. Even though, she noted for herself with some amusement, it might actually validate all those 'boosts your immune system' ads certain companies put out for their latest overpriced placebo line. Still… "Yes, that might work," she said. "But we might have to run this past Dr Fraiser. She's the medical expert on the base." And Sam's friend had the most experience with alien biology of all the medical professionals on Earth, something that a lot of experts were still struggling with. Very much like Sam's situation, actually.

"OK! Let's go!" Entrapta jumped up from her seat, her hair sweeping up her presentation materials and recorder. Emily, standing behind her, beeped. "Oh, yes, you can stop that, Emily!"

The holoprojection in the centre of the lab vanished.

Sam realised that Entrapta was about to head to the infirmary. "Ah… I think it would be better if we ask Janet to meet us here," she said. "We wouldn't want to disturb her work."

“Oh?” Entrapta stopped halfway to the door, and Emily also came to a halt a yard behind her. “But she’s got all the special gear in her lab, right?”

Of course, Sam’s friend wanted to start experimenting right away. She should have realised that. Sam smiled. “We’re still in the planning stage. We need to prepare any experiments properly, I think, and then set up a proper lab for it. Janet’s infirmary is meant to treat people.” Even though they also had had to deal with other emergencies there from time to time. Of course, that fell under treating people as well if you wanted to be technical.

“Ah.” Entrapta blinked, then nodded. Her hair, tools still held in tendrils, bopped, and she turned around. “So… let’s call her!”

Sam smiled and reached for her phone.

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Thule Air Force Base, Greenland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

Catra was growing less fond of this stupid ice base - and the memories of that stupid mission in the war that they brought - with every minute she had to watch Sweet Bee make a fool of herself. “Why do you care about the ranks of the prisoners? They’re both former System Lords or whatever, and now they’re prisoners. Anything beyond that is stupid. Just pick one and talk to them!” she snapped.

“It’s not stupid!” the moron insisted with a glare that was probably meant to be scathing but only made her look more stupid to someone who had faced Shadow Weaver and Hordak at their worst. “There are forms to be observed. Not that you would be familiar with that concept!”

Catra scoffed in return. She was familiar with all the princess stuff and rules - from preparing for the Princess Prom, and just hanging out with Adora, of course - but she didn’t care for it. But, speaking of… “Just use the rules of the Princess Prom to determine who

you talk to first." She managed not to add 'moron', but it was a close call.

"That doesn't apply here!" Sweet Bee retorted. "We're visitors, not their guests! And they're prisoners, not hosts! This isn't like Princess Prom at all!"

Catra bared her fangs in a grin. "Then it's simple, as representative of our hosts, Jack can decide who you will see first."

O'Neill shot her a glare, but she ignored him. He had brought them here, so he could sort this out! And it wasn't as if talking to Osiris or Seth first would make any difference, in Catra's opinion. Both would do their best to lie in an attempt to turn them.

"Yes," Glimmer was quick to agree - probably as tired of this shit as Catra. "Just pick one. Sweet Bee can blame you if one of the Goa'uld complains. You don't mind that, do you?"

Judging by O'Neill's grin, he loved getting blamed by the Goa'uld for anything that annoyed or hurt them. "Alright. So, let's talk to Seth first."

"Why Seth?" Sweet Bee immediately asked.

"He's got the shorter name," O'Neill told her with a serious expression.

Sweet Bee blinked, opened her mouth, then closed it and frowned. But, for a change, she didn't complain. "Very well," she said, sounding very put on.

Catra refrained from offering a high-five to O'Neill.

The two prisoners had stopped arguing halfway into the princess's tantrum and had watched them intently, which was a change from their earlier behaviour. Catra wondered how well they were holding together without a sapient host, but asking now would set off Sweet Bee again.

“Greetings, Lord Seth,” the moron in question began after O’Neill had pushed a few buttons and nodded. “I am Princess Sweet Bee of Etheria. This is Prince Peekablue. We would like to ask you a few questions about the Goa’uld. This isn’t an interrogation, though; we are merely curious about your society.” She bowed, if not terribly deep. “And we aren’t members of the Princess Alliance so we have no quarrel with you.”

Peekablue bowed with a bit more flair, but the way he wasn’t really focused on anything ruined the effect.

“Greetings, Princess. Prince.” Seth didn’t bow, but as a snake, that would have looked weird anyway. “You are not members of the Alliance, but you are with them?”

“We’re on a diplomatic visit to Earth representing a coalition of independent realms on Etheria,” Sweet Bee told him.

Catra could see the snake perk up at that. Like an instructor spotting a cadet about to screw up.

This was going to go great, she thought with a scoff.

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“...so, you see, I was not involved with this war - I was stranded on Earth thousands of years ago, before any of the countries waging war today existed, and did my best to live my life without being noticed by the local rulers.”

Jack O’Neill rolled his eyes at Seth’s lies and spoke up before Sweet Bee could comment: “That’s what you call creating suicide cults all over the place?”

“Suicide cults?” the princess asked, turning to glance at Jack. “What do you mean?”

“He recruited people to worship him and then had them kill themselves when he tired of them,” Jack explained. Had she missed the barb from Osiris earlier?

"It's a bit more complicated than that, but, essentially, that's correct," Daniel added.

"I was worshipped as a god, and when I had to go into hiding after the authorities started oppressing my faith, my followers, unwilling to live without me, decided to kill themselves. And they were facing torture and death at the hands of the human rulers anyway since they had forsaken their fake religion in favour of following me," Seth retorted. "Instead of being burned alive, they decided to end their lives on their terms."

"Humans kill those who don't follow your religion?" Sweet Bee gasped.

"No!" Jack snapped. Of course, she would focus on that, and not on the fact that Seth had driven his worshippers to suicide!

"Well, several countries still have the death penalty for apostasy," Daniel unhelpfully pointed out. "Although that hasn't been the case in Western, I mean, Alliance countries, for a long time."

"I have heard about your zealots and how they wish to murder us for living our lives differently." Sweet Bee nodded.

"Oh, yes," Seth chimed in again. "They are very intolerant of other religions - a natural reaction, of course, when their god doesn't exist."

"Says the parasite posing as a god," Jack shot back.

"Of course, someone who believes that there is only one god - and a god who is conveniently intangible and only acts through his worshippers at that - would disparage other religions." Seth's synthetic voice was far too smooth for Jack's taste. He had to talk to Carter about that. "You call me a false god, yet I provided for my faithful. I gave them guidance, sharing my wisdom with my chosen ones, healing them in need and offering a safe home for those who wished to live a life different from that mandated by those zealots."

Between advertising and Cold War propaganda, Jack had heard a lot of bullshit, but this took the cake. "You used technology and lies to fool gullible people into worshipping you as a god!"

"You are a false god tricking the Tau'ri," Teal'c added. "And you abandoned your faithful as soon as it became convenient."

"And yet, I offered more than your god ever did, Colonel O'Neill," Seth said. "Which is why, as soon as you noticed me, you stormed my home, killed my followers and captured me even though I had never done anything to hurt your country. So much for the freedom of religion that you tout so often."

Was the snake seriously claiming that his freedom of religion had been violated?

Daniel spoke up before Jack found the right words to react. "Well, while, technically, your followers' freedom of religion was violated, you also committed several crimes. Even leaving aside the fact that you enslaved your host…"

"My followers willingly embraced my gifts!" Seth cut in.

Daniel ignored it and continued: "...you also gathered illegal weapons and used violence and illegal drugs to control your followers. And I am sure you violated zoning laws with your construction."

Jack blinked, then snorted at the last line. If Daniel tried, he could snark with the best of them.

And Sweet Bee seemed, at last, reconsidering her sympathy for the poor captured false god. "You used drugs on your people?"

"Mind control drugs," Glimmer added.

"That is how the false gods operate - they use all manner of tricks to deceive, control and enslave their victims," Teal'c said. "And those they cannot control or enslave, they kill."

“One of them has enslaved Sha’re, my wife.” Daniel glared at Seth. “They took over her body as their own.”

“I had nothing to do with that. In my time, being chosen as a host for your god was a great honour,” the snake lied. “And if we are criticising manipulative practises, what about threatening people with eternal torment if they do not follow your god? Or putting those who refuse to convert to the sword? I have seen countless atrocities committed in the name of gods, yet not once I saw any of those gods actually appear. You call me a false god, but you worship an imaginary god!”

Someone had a grudge against Christianity. “If someone appeared claiming to be God and trying to prove it through trickery, we’d call them false as well,” Jack told him.

“So, the only god you accept is one who never appears. As I have said before, that is very convenient for you.” The snake turned its ugly head and looked at Adora. “Do you call her a fake goddess as well?”

“I’m no goddess!” Adora snapped at once.

“And yet, you are worshipped as a goddess. And after you saved your faithful, you continued to provide them with guidance and healing, generously sharing your divine gifts,” Seth told her.

Jack gritted his teeth. Seth must have picked up quite a lot from TV before they captured him.

“That doesn’t make me a goddess!”

“Goddess, princess… those are mere semantics,” Seth said. “We are leaders with wisdom and powers beyond our followers’. Call it divine right or noblesse oblige, but do we not have a duty to provide for those bereft of our gifts?”

And Sweet Bee nodded. “Of course! A ruler is supposed to protect, help and lead her people! That is why we have our powers!”

“But we shouldn’t be worshipped as gods!” Adora spat.

“So much for freedom of religion.” The snake managed to even sound smug through the computer.

Jack clenched his teeth. This wasn’t going according to plan.

“If there was such a duty, then you failed it every time you abandoned your cults. Leaders worthy of that position do not sacrifice their followers to save themselves.” Teal’c slowly inclined his head.

And Sweet Bee blinked.

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“Yes!” Adora nodded emphatically. Teal’c had cut to the heart of the matter. “If Seth were a princess, he’d have abandoned his kingdom as soon as an enemy showed up that looked dangerous,” she told Sweet Bee. The other princess had to see that!

“Ugh.” Mermista scoffed.

Adora winced - her friend would have some words about people abandoning their princess and kingdom, but, fortunately, Mermista wasn’t voicing them. Adora really should have thought about her phrasing.

“It’s worse than that,” Catra cut in. “Seth here used his followers’ deaths to hide his own disappearance. Once his followers were dead, he could kill his host, take a new one, and disappear - with everyone involved dead, no one would look for him.” She bared her fangs. “Killing everyone was the plan from the start.”

“Yeah, like a parasite, he sucked his followers dry, and when they were no longer useful to him, he killed them without another thought,” Jack added. “That’s how the Go’auld are.”

“That’s a gross misrepresentation!” Seth protested. “When I was openly worshipped, before Osiris and his wife tried to topple Ra

and I was caught between them, my faithful were cared for! If not for the Tau'ri hunting down all those who didn't follow their religion, my community would have endured without any trouble!"

Daniel scoffed - it was weird to see him sneer like that, Adora realised. "You would have killed them anyway since you were hiding from Ra as well, and having a lasting cult would have exposed you."

Perfuma gasped in the background.

"No! The fault lies with the intolerant and violent Tau'ri!" Seth snapped.

He didn't sound so smooth and persuasive any more, Adora noticed. He sounded desperate.

And Sweet Bee had realised that as well. The princess frowned as she addressed him. "Did you try to save your followers?"

"Of course! I tried everything - they only chose death when there was no way out anymore!"

"That's a lie!" Daniel snapped. "We've looked into the records of your cults and their ends - they weren't hunted by the authorities - in almost all cases, they were discovered after your followers had killed themselves!"

"And they didn't choose anything," Glimmer chimed in with a scowl. "You used drugs on them to control their minds."

"Yes! We have the records for that as well." Daniel nodded.

For a second, Seth didn't say anything - Adora could see him twist. Then his synthetic voice rang out again. "Those records are false! They're trying to frame me so they can fool you," he told Sweet Bee.

But the princess shook her head. "Why didn't you claim that from the beginning? Or when those drugs were mentioned the first

time?”

Seth once more hesitated to answer.

Sweet Bee nodded. “I don’t think you can be trusted, Lord Seth.” She turned to Jack. “I would like to speak to Lord Osiris now.”

“Wait! This is a plot! You can’t trust…”

Jack pushed a button, and Seth’s voice was cut off in the middle of his sentence.

Adora suppressed a sigh. That had been tiring. At least Sweet Bee was as critical towards Seth’s claims as she was towards the Alliance. And Seth hadn’t had good arguments for his lies. She could only hope Osiris wasn’t going to do any better.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

“...and that’s why we wanted to ask you about this,” Samantha Carter finished her explanation, Entrapta nodding along.

“I see.” Janet nodded as well and shifted on her seat in their lab. “You want to use genetic engineering to… create a symbiotic strain of bacteria to boost or replace a failing immune system.”

“Exactly!” Entrapta beamed at her. “And we need your help to do that properly. Without accidentally creating a bioweapon. Or a sapient species that needs human guts to survive.”

Janet’s smile grew more than a little forced. “I think I can help you avoid either outcome,” she said.

Sam didn’t miss the glance her friend shot at her and winced a little. In hindsight, their explanation sounded a bit… well, it might leave the wrong impression. Even though Sam couldn’t honestly

exclude both possible results that Entrapta had mentioned. Not when magic and Ancient technology were involved.

Janet sighed and went on. "But I don't think I can offer a lot of help with your actual project. I am a doctor, not a geneticist."

That would have earned her a Star Trek joke if the Colonel was here, Sam knew.

Entrapta was still beaming at Janet. "Oh, don't worry about that! We've got so many ideas to test, one of them should work out! And we've got the First Ones research data to use as well - they knew a lot about creating new species, you know!"

"I see." The narrowed glance at Sam intensified.

Sam winced again and hoped she wasn't blushing. There was no reason to be embarrassed, anyway - testing multiple approaches was how you did research as a scientist. Well, one of the ways you did research. Even if it did sound a bit like what a mad scientist in a B-movie would say.

At least the Colonel wasn't here. He'd have a field day teasing Sam about this.

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Thule Air Force Base, Greenland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"So, you have seen through Seth's pathetic lies."

Catra sighed. Loudly, not softly. Adora shot her a glance, but she ignored it. Osiris went straight to gloating about his brother's failure, and that wasn't… well, Catra knew how stupid it was to focus on beating your rival when you should be focusing on actually achieving your objectives. Knew it very, very well from personal experience. Painful experience.

"Yes, Lord Osiris," Sweet Bee replied. "And now I would like to hear what you have to say."

At least the princess didn't apologise for not talking to this snake first.

"About Seth? Or about my current, unjustified predicament?"

"About you and your peers, the other System Lords." Sweet Bee inclined her head.

Catra narrowed her eyes for a moment. If this were someone else, Catra would consider that a smart attempt to get intel. But since it was Sweet Bee… She glanced at Peekablue, but the prince was still doing his 'obviously using my farsight power' thing and staring at a corner of the room. If he started drooling, someone would have to get a picture.

"Well, technically, I was stripped of my position by Ra after Seth manipulated me and my beloved wife into opposing him," Osiris replied.

"But you did try to depose him, didn't you?"

"Yes, I did. Isis…" Osiris sighed, a bit overly dramatic, in Catra's opinion. "My beloved was always ambitious, and I believed she would be a better ruler than Ra - an opinion, I think, that history vindicated."

Sweet Bee slowly nodded but didn't seem to agree.

"Well, getting pushed off Earth by a bronze-age revolution isn't exactly a feather in old Ra's cap," O'Neill commented.

"Isis warned him not to underestimate Earth's magic," Osiris said. "But, as he was wont to do, he ignored her advice."

Now that was interesting.

"Earth's magic?" Daniel spoke up. "What do you know about it?"

"I was there when it grew from primitive rituals into sophisticated spellcraft." Osiris sounded smug even in the bot voice he was using. Catra wondered how Entrapta and Sam had managed that.

"And all under your nose?" O'Neill shook his head.

"Isis was a patron of magic. Under her guidance, her faithful advanced by leaps and bounds."

"And she was guiding them despite not being able to use magic herself?" Glimmer scoffed. "Or was she just trying to find a way to use a sorceress as a host without losing access to their magic?"

Osiris hesitated a moment. "Can you fault her for that? This power, so versatile, so… close, yet out of our reach. Who would, in our place, not have attempted to secure it for themselves?"

That sounded honest, in Catra's opinion. And quite understandable, from a certain point of view. But, she added to herself with a smirk, to some, it sounded quite bad…

"Magic is a talent you're born with. A gift as well as an obligation," Sweet Bee said. With a frown, she added: "It's not something you can take for yourself as if it were a mere physical good."

"Yeah," O'Neill chimed in with a smug grin. "How could it be proof of your divine right to rule if everyone could just grab it as well?"

"There is a difference between magic powers and the talent for sorcery, Colonel O'Neill," Sweet Bee retorted. "Casting spells does not make you a princess."

Catra snorted, softly, at the scowl that briefly appeared on O'Neill's face. Sweet Bee might not have been aware of his talent for sorcery or how he loathed it, but she had certainly hit him in an uncomfortable spot.

"Yeah, yeah. Those Ancients certainly knew how to pick the leaders for their experimental subjects." O'Neill shot back.

“The same people who built a network of Stargates linking the galaxy’s worlds, millions of years ago? As far as endorsement of our rule is concerned, I could think of far worse choices.”

Before O’Neill could go on about democracy again, Osiris cut in: “Indeed. And the Goa’uld inherited their works - the Stargates and their technology. To take care of the galaxy in their place.”

“To enslave and oppress people, you mean,” Glimmer corrected him. “It was all for your own power, not for your subjects’ welfare.”

“Even a god’s power is limited - if not by their resources, then by their peers. Isis and I did what we could, and if not for Seth and Ra, we would have done far more.” He sighed. “But we were betrayed and defeated, then imprisoned in stasis jars - separated from each other. When I woke up, it was to the devastating news that my beloved had died when her pod had failed.”

“You have my condolences,” Sweet Bee told him. “So, you were a prisoner for all this time?”

“When my body was sealed away, Ra was the ruler of the Goa’uld Empire, and his seat was on Earth. To find out that he was dead, and that Earth was fighting the Empire, was another shock.” Osiris sighed again. “Unfortunately, the Tau’ri count me as their enemy even though not even once did I fight them.”

“You only oppressed and enslaved our ancestors,” Daniel said.

“If left to their own devices, they would have fought each other - as your history after the rebellion showed.” Osiris shook his head, which looked weird for a snake. “And it was a different time. Every Lord was sometimes forced to use harsh measures for the greater good. Back then, few Tau’ri had the necessary knowledge and wisdom to understand leadership. Isis and I planned to change that. We meant to educate our faithful so they would grow in wisdom, could be trusted to lead their own. But, as you know, it was not to be. Our plans, our goals, were foiled by treachery.”

“Why would you plan to abolish your own rule?” Sweet Bee asked. “If you’re the most capable ruler, why should you step down? That makes no sense.”

Osiris seemed surprised. Had he expected a princess to support democracy? Catra snorted again.

He recovered quickly, though. “Of course not. But even a wise ruler requires skilled help. Administrators. Guards. Servants.”

“Slaves,” Daniel added with a scoff. “No matter their titles, they were slaves to your whims.”

“What was the alternative? No Tau’ri, back in my time, could have been truly free. They were at the mercy of the weather. Or anyone more powerful than them. That was how things were: The strong ruled, and the weak obeyed. And have things truly changed?”

“Yeah, we have those things called ‘rights’ now,” O’Neill snapped.

“You enslaved your faithful?” Sweet Bee sounded shocked.

“That’s a matter of definitions,” Osiris replied quickly. “And, ultimately, a meaningless label. If you are not the most powerful, then you are bound to obey someone else, and does it then matter whether you are called a slave or a subordinate? You obey either way.”

Sweet Bee scowled at the Goa’uld. “Being more powerful does not give you the right to force your will on others! The very reason we are here is because we do not obey the Alliance’s decrees!”

Catra grinned as she saw the Goa’uld recoil once he realised his mistake. He really put his foot in it there.

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Educational Issues Part 5

Thule Air Force Base, Greenland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

Well, that went better than expected.

Jack O'Neill was smiling when they left the cell block - well, the aquarium section would be more appropriate, given the cells were special habitats for Goa'uld prisoners, but his suggestion for a name change had been ignored. Still, what mattered was that the two snakes had, by just being themselves, shown their annoying visitor that the Goa'uld were not misunderstood nice aliens but really as bad as everyone who knew them - even or especially the Tok'ra, who would know best - claimed.

Alright, it would have been better if the killer argument hadn't been 'they fail at being good absolute rulers for their faithful', but in politics - and this was politics - you had to take what you could get.

As soon as the doors of the lift carrying them out of the special section closed behind them, he clapped his hands together. "Alright, kids! Now, what's next on the itinerary?"

"We get Frosta to stop playing with the snow and ice, make her clean up the airstrip and leave this forsaken dump for someplace warmer and nicer," Catra said.

Right. Jack had almost forgotten that the kid was still out there. Although it was nice that she had decided to play for once instead of acting all 'serious ruling princess'. "Sounds good," he said. "Any preference about the next destination?"

"Hawaii!" Perfuma blurted out. "I want to meet the plants of Earth!"

"Geneva," Her Honeyness declared. "We need to talk to other leaders of your planet."

Like hell! Jack managed to keep smiling, even though the last thing he wanted was to let the twit talk to the United Nations. It had been difficult enough to keep her from the Russians and Chinese at Stargate Command, and that had only worked because the Alliance had declared this an Alliance matter thanks to their majority in the Command Council.

Unfortunately, flat-out denying this request was, apparently, not possible for reasons of diplomacy. Or something. Jack had received clear orders about that, and Glimmer had confirmed it - and she didn't like it either.

Now, delaying it, on the other hand, was totally fine. So he grinned. "And we'll travel to Geneva afterwards," he told her. "We're still waiting for permission to enter Switzerland - we have to respect their sovereignty, after all. Might doesn't make right, as you know."

Judging by the glare he received from Daniel, he was laying it on a bit too thick. And Sweet Bee was narrowing her eyes at him as well. "As far as I understand, Earth's United Nations meet in New York as well, which is part of the United States and, therefore, should be easily accessible."

"Well, yes," Jack admitted. "But that's the problem - we don't want you to claim that we rigged the meeting by having it happen in our country. Since Switzerland is neutral and not part of the Alliance, this won't be a problem there."

Sweet Bee still frowned at him, but Peekablue nodded. "That seems fair. And I am curious about this Hawaii myself."

"Great! So, who's going to tell Frosta that playtime's over?" Jack asked - they had just reached the top level.

"Not it!" Catra announced. "I'm not going to step outside in this weather. And Frosta wouldn't listen to me anyway," she added with a grin.

“I’ll do it,” Adora said, with a sigh that told Jack she was used to this.

“Alright!” Glimmer nodded. “Call if you need help.”

It didn’t sound sincere to Jack - and as soon as they entered the hangar, everyone but Adora made a beeline for the shuttle and its warm passenger compartment.

Jack as well - his job description didn’t include ‘wrangle ice princesses in the middle of Greenland’. “I’ll be starting the pre-flight check.”

“Is that really necessary?” Mermista asked.

“It’s standard procedure,” he told her. “If it flies, you do a pre-flight check.” Even though the shuttles were supposed to be as reliable as Jeeps. Jack had heard similar claims about other vehicles.

“We just turned the engines on in the Horde flyers,” Catra commented as they reached the shuttle.

“And let me guess: If you lost one to a malfunction, there were more where it came from?” Jack asked, baring his teeth.

“Yes.” She matched his grin. “Cut response times down, though.”

“I bet it did.” It seemed as if the Horde had studied the Russian way of doing things. Well, they had lost the war despite putting tanks against archers. And against magic and trick arrows that would make Green Arrow green with envy… Jack blinked. Good thing he hadn’t said that out loud.

He snorted anyway as he walked around the shuttle, checking the engines and the landing gear, and the fuselage in general.

“You don’t do this in the field,” Bow commented.

“We do it unless it’s an emergency,” Jack corrected him. If you were under fire, all that counted was getting away as soon as possible. Though Air Force planes generally didn’t land in the field. Or if they did, they didn’t take off afterwards. But they were in a hangar, on an Air Force base, and airmen were watching - and Jack knew what kind of damage it did if you ‘relaxed’ such procedures or let the enlisted think they weren’t critical. “Well, it checks out.”

He stepped inside to do the rest of the checklist.

*****

Over the Pacific Ocean, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

“Oh, imagine sailing on this ocean! To boldly go where no Dragon’s Daughter has gone before! Adventure!”

“Ugh. You mean, to boldly sink where no Dragon’s Daughter has sunk before?”

“Ah, my dear Mermista! No ship will sink if you are with me! Just imagine - the Dragon’s Daughter VII, sailing the seven seas of Earth! The two of us, travelling to the distant ports of a strange planet! Enjoying alien sunsets and fresh breezes! Oh, I wish we were flying so low that we could open the windows and smell the ocean breeze!”

“The windows of a shuttle don’t open.”

“The airlock then!”

“Ugh, no!”

Adora grinned at the antics of her friends. First Frosta playing in Greenland, now Mermista and Seahawk enjoying the Pacific Ocean - well, one of them was, but Adora was sure Mermista would like it as well, even if she didn’t like to show it. And Hawaii would be a paradise for Perfuma with all those new plants.

It was almost ironic that this trip was the result of Sweet Bee's stubborn refusal to trust Adora and her friends about the Goa'uld. Or maybe it was ironic - Adora wasn't sure. But this was turning into a nice trip.

"I don't see any difference between this and our own oceans," Sweet Bee said.

"That's because you aren't a sailor!"

"No, it's because she's a fool who thinks she knows best," Mermista said with a sniff.

"I *know* I don't know best - unlike others I might name." Sweet Bee sneered in return. "And that's why I am here: To find out the truth directly from the source."

"Well, so far, you've found out that we told you the truth about the Goa'uld." Glimmer cut in. Adora didn't have to look at her friend to know she was smiling smugly.

"That remains to be seen. Two people - especially since they are considered criminals by their own people - cannot be taken as examples for all Goa'uld. What if someone else would judge all of Etheria by the example that the Horde set?" Sweet Bee retorted.

"Well, in that case, they'd clearly overestimate you," Catra commented with a snort from Adora's side.

Adora reached over and gently patted Catra's thigh. Her lover was trying to hide it, but Adora knew that this was a sore spot for her - and she was pretty sure that Sweet Bee knew it as well. So much for this being a nice trip. At least they hadn't seen that Great Pacific Garbage Patch Entrapta had mentioned once - that would have probably ruined Mermista's mood. More than Sweet Bee's comments had, at least.

"This is your captain speaking. We're on our final approach to Hickam Air Force Base. Please fasten your seatbelts and return

your tray table to its full upright and locked position," Jack called back from the cockpit.

Daniel snorted, as did Catra and Bow.

"It's a joke about civilian aeroplanes," Catra told Adora.

"It's what they tell passengers before they set down," Bow added.

"Ah."

"And that's supposed to be funny?" Sweet Bee asked.

"We're in a military shuttle, not a civilian aeroplane. Procedures are different," Bow explained. "At least, I think they are."

"They are. We don't have tray tables," Catra said. "Also, don't cover the airstrip with plants," she added with a glance at Perfuma. "They might not be as chill as in Thule."

"Of course, I wouldn't do that!" Perfuma said with a huff. "That would be irresponsible!"

"I didn't know that they actually needed the entire strip for their shuttles - we didn't need it!" Frosta defended herself.

"What? Oh, no, I am sorry; I didn't mean it like that," Perfuma told her.

"So, how did you mean it?"

Catra snorted again, and Adora sighed as the two bickered while the shuttle set down.

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Hickam Air Force Base, Hawaii, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"Ah, the smell of the sea! The scent of… Adventure!"

“It smells a bit like the Fright Zone, actually.”

Adora sniffed the air. Mermista was right - it smelt a bit like it.

“That’s the Air Force base behind us,” Jack said.

“Aren’t we technically still in the base?” Bow asked.

“One of your Air Force Bases is in an icy wasteland, and this one has a beach? Talk about differences!” Scorpia said. “How do you decide who gets sent where?”

“I bet the screwups go to Greenland,” Catra commented. “Kyle would be stationed there for sure.”

“There’s nothing wrong with snow and ice!” Frosta protested. “At least you don’t have to worry about heatstroke and bug bites!”

“Just frostbite. And you wouldn’t have to worry about heatstroke if you were wearing sensible clothes.” Glimmer sounded a bit… annoyed. Well, it had taken a while to clean up the ice on the airstrips, and she might have felt responsible.

“This is amazing! But I hoped to visit a jungle, not a beach.” Perfuma pouted a little.

“Oh, we will, don’t worry!” Jack grinned. “But I thought it would be nice to hit the beach while we’re organising a trip to Waimea Bay.”

“Meaning, you wanted to hit the beach,” Daniel said.

“What do you have to organise? Can’t we just take the shuttle and fly there instead?” Sweet Bee asked.

“Security has to be set up,” Jack explained. “And that’s going to take a while. You’re VIPs, after all.”

“I am sure we can handle any threat on Earth,” Sweet Bee retorted. “Peekablue can spot any danger from afar.”

"Only the danger I know."

Adora blinked. Prince Peekablue had looked out of it, yet he had obviously been listening to their talk.

"He's a better spy than I thought," Catra muttered next to her.

Adora was forced to agree. Of course, Peekablue would be experienced in using his power - and he had been a member of the first Princess Alliance, so she should have expected that.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"...and rumours of another delegation of aliens visiting Earth are spreading. We have eyewitnesses reporting shuttle flights from places all over the world, and we are doing our best to match them to scheduled flights to exclude those and find unscheduled flights, although with the information blackout for military traffic, that remains a challenge…"

Samantha Carter shook her head at the television. Trying to find the Etherian visitors using a method like that… Even if all shuttle flights were logged in advance as a rule, you'd still have to consider spontaneous flights in response to an emergency. Or a summons from Washington or Brussels.

Or a general wishing to go home for the weekend, she added with another shake of her head - she had no doubt that with the continuing proliferation of shuttles, sooner or later, the brass would start treating them as helicopter rides for their personal use. She had heard a rumour that General Naird was planning to use one for a personal trip to the moon under the guise of 'familiarising the pilots under my command with the route in case there's an emergency'.

And, speaking of trips into space… She checked the time, then leaned over and asked Siller at the table next to them: "Can we

check CNN?"

"Sure, Captain." He pushed a button, and the channel changed.

Perfect timing - CNN's special report about the upcoming Mars Mission had just started. Interest in the mission had dropped a little since the news of the first Alliance operation on another planet had been released, but it was still a scientific landmark, in Sam's opinion.

Or would be once they actually got it launched - they just announced another delay for unspecified 'technical reasons'. I should look into this, Sam thought. I bet I could help with sorting out those issues. If they were technical issues in the first place and not politically motivated - Sam was somewhat familiar with the way NASA operated.

In any case, it meant that there wouldn't be any more interesting news on that front. "Thank you. That was all I wanted to know," she told Siller.

"Alright." A click later, the channel changed again.

"...and PETA has released a controversial statement yesterday," an anchorman commented on screen. *"What do you make of it, James?"*

"Well, John, we already knew that they think eating meat is murder, but now they're claiming that eating meat is cannibalism, citing the existence of aliens with similar features as animals as proof, and have launched a new advertising campaign to emphasise their point."

Sam sighed and prepared to see pictures of Etherian minotaurs next to Earth longhorns. She wasn't aware of any species that would line up with pigs or chickens, but there was a satyr-like species, and some people ate goats, so that would probably…

"What's this shit?"

“Turn that off! We’re eating here!”

“That’s disgusting!”

Siller quickly changed the channel again, and another news report from Europe replaced a not-quite-graphic scene of a butchered minotaur being put on a grill. The special effects were quite good for an ad, Sam noted, and the production value seemed quite high. Still…

“Do they think we eat people on Etheria?” Entrapta added, looking shocked.

Sam clenched her teeth, mentally cursing whoever came up with the ad, and started explaining PETA’s campaigns to her friend. “No, they want people on Earth to feel as if they were eating people when eating meat. They think…”

*****

Waimea Bay, O’ahu, Hawaii, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

“Another beach?” Catra raised her eyebrows as they stepped out of the shuttle. “You really want a vacation, don’t you?” she asked O’Neill. She was tempted to ask if he just wanted to see them in bathing suits, but without Sam being present, it would lack any sting.

“There’s a jungle walk here, to a waterfall,” he told her. “But if someone doesn’t want to walk through a jungle, this should be a nice spot to wait for the others to return.”

“It’s a famous surf spot,” Daniel added.

“Surfing?” Mermista asked.

“Wave riding,” Catra told her.

“You have wave riding on Earth?” The princess perked up and turned to look at the rolling waves.

“For a famous spot, this seems rather empty,” Sweet Bee commented.

“We had to move out the tourists for security reasons,” O’Neill told her.

“And they’ll blame us, I suppose.”

“We didn’t tell them why we needed the place cleared, so they’ll blame the government or the military, as usual,” O’Neill shrugged.

“That’s still not right. We aren’t here to disrupt the lives of others.” Sweet Bee frowned.

“They’ll survive being cut off from their favourite beach for a few hours.” O’Neill grinned. “Besides, I am not sure they could handle Mermista.”

Catra looked at the shore. Indeed, Mermista was in the water, riding the first wave. Unlike the Tau’ri, she wasn’t using a surfboard.

Catra took a step closer to Adora, just in case Mermista planned to ‘accidentally’ hit her with a wave, but the princess seemed to simply enjoy the water. Any time now, she would probably change into a mermaid or something…

“I will stay here as well,” Frosta announced. “It’s much too hot to walk around.”

“Just create some ice to cool down,” Catra told her.

The kid glared at her, then sniffed. “I don’t want to deal with bugs, either.”

“And that’s perfectly fine!” Adora cut in. “So, who’s coming with us to the waterfall?”

*****

As it turned out, the 'jungle walk' was a botanic garden or whatever they called it. Not an actual untouched wilderness. And the waterfalls were not quite as impressive as they had sounded. Not when you were familiar with Bright Moon's waterfall. And the pool below didn't look very appealing, at least to Catra. Not that she planned to go swimming, anyway - trying to get her fur clean of the algae, muck and other stuff in it afterwards was a nightmare. Almost as bad as cleaning up after swamp training.

"Oh, look at that! Another new flower!"

"It's very pretty!"

At least Perfuma was having fun. Which meant Scorpia would be happy as well.

"This is… it's far too hot! And why can't you do anything about the insects attacking me?"

And Sweet Bee was annoyed, which meant Catra was having fun. "They probably think you're a bee," she told the twit.

"I'm not a bee!" the princess shot back.

"But you do have some, ah, aspects of a bee?" Daniel asked. "Maybe your scent is similar to the scent of a bee on Earth?"

"Are you insinuating that I smell?" Sweet Bee sounded outraged.

Daniel opened his mouth to apologise, but Catra was faster. "You do smell." She wrinkled her nose for emphasis. "All that sweat…"

"What?"

"Catra!" Adora frowned at her, as expected. But the opportunity to get a dig in had been too much to miss.

Sweet Bee swatted at another bug trying to land on her. “This is insufferable!”

“Well, we can’t just spray the whole island with RAID,” O’Neill said with a shrug. “So, I am sorry, but you’ll have to endure this for a bit longer.”

“I could probably build a bug-repeller, but… I would need some materials, and it would take me some time,” Bow said.

“Oh, let me help!” Perfuma beamed at them. “I have a solution!”

“Ah… you can control bugs? Not just plants?” O’Neill looked wary.

With good reason - Perfuma looked excited. And enthusiastic. A bit like Entrapta when faced with something dangerous but interesting. Catra felt the fur on her neck rise.

“No. Well, not directly. But I can control plants, and through that, affect bugs!” Perfuma gestured, and the flowers at the side of the path suddenly grew in size. By a lot. “That should smell far more appealing to bugs than Sweet Bee, now.”

Indeed, the bugs buzzing around quickly changed course and flew straight to the giant flowers. Which were dripping yellow liquid on the ground, Catra realised. Honey?

“Uh…” Daniel blinked. “What exactly did you do?”

“I increased the size and yield of the flowers here,” Perfuma explained. “And the quality of the nectar.”

“Uh. That sounds like… a major change to the flower,” Daniel pointed out.

“Oh.” It was Perfuma’s turn to blink. “I guess I should fix that, then?”

“I think so, yes.” O’Neill managed to not sound too sarcastic. Catra was sure it took a lot of effort.

But by now, most of the new flowers were covered with bugs. And more were arriving. A lot more.

"Ah. Maybe wait until we leave?" Bow suggested.

"Just how much did you improve the nectar?" Glimmer asked.

"Well, I wanted it to be so good, no bee would bother Sweet Bee…"

"Great. You produced bee crack." O'Neill shook his head.

"Sorry! Ah, what is 'crack'?" Pefuma asked.

While Daniel explained, Catra looked at Peekablue. The prince was staring at something only he could see. And she had no idea what.

*****

Above the Atlantic Ocean, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"I am really sorry. I didn't mean to endanger your ecosystem. I should have known better!"

Yes, the princess with magic plant control should have known better than to meddle with plants. But Jack O'Neill didn't say that. That wouldn't be very diplomatic, and Perfuma meant well. And he was flying the shuttle, so he couldn't exactly focus on the conversation, anyway.

Catra snorted. "No harm done."

"Except to the poor plants and the poor insects." Perfuma sighed.

Jack didn't really care about that. Wiping out both plants and bugs might have been a bit extreme, but he had been improvising, and with that sort of stuff, it was better to err on the side of caution. And of a higher blast radius.

And adapting some of Bow's trick arrows to create an incendiary charge large enough to burn down the entire affected area had been fun. Especially since Jack didn't have to explain the result to the local authorities. It was all classified. Fortunately - if the environmentalists got wind of this, it would be a disaster.

"You restored the plants. And the bugs will recover," Adora told her.

"But still…" Perfuma sighed. "I should have known not to introduce such changes to the ecosystem. Even though I didn't introduce new organisms but simply improved existing plants, and so it shouldn't have violated any of your laws."

"You restored the destroyed area," Daniel added. "That's more than we managed in a lot of places."

"What do you mean?" Perfuma asked.

"Well, a lot of fragile ecosystems are endangered by illegal logging and poaching," Daniel said. "For example, we've lost huge swaths of the Amazon rainforest to both. So, you actually did quite well in comparison."

Jack couldn't help snorting. That was a backhanded compliment if he ever heard one. Daniel would be embarrassed about it, no doubt.

"What? You *lost* forests?"

"I think we told you that, didn't we?" Adora spoke up. "Lots of Earth was treated like the Fright Zone - the forests were cut down and turned into fields. Or settlements."

"Or deserts," Bow added.

"I didn't… I thought you just had more deserts than Etheria. To think you are losing forests…But… I can help with that!" Perfuma sounded enthusiastic. "Just like I helped with the Fright Zone! And I don't have to introduce new plants or create living cities, or

anything, I just have to restore what was there before - that shouldn't be any problem! Who do I talk to?"

"Well, there are several organisations fighting to preserve nature and the environment…" Daniel started to explain.

Jack felt a cold shiver run down his spine. And he had thought handling Sweet Bee was the problem he should focus on!

*****

Above Geneva Airport, Switzerland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

Landing a shuttle was easy compared to landing a plane. Very easy. Which was a very good thing since Jack O'Neill kept getting distracted by the discussion in the main compartment behind him. I really should have grabbed a crew, he thought. Or asked Bow to fly it. But I wanted some stick time, and this is the result - stuck in the cockpit while our friends plot the destruction of our agricultural sector.

"...and I could change the plants to need less fertiliser or less fertile soil. Or both. That way, you need fewer fields to grow the same amount of crops, and we could restore more of the jungle and forests."

"Earth has enough, more than enough, food to feed everyone - people still starve because they don't share, Perfuma."

"What? That can't be right, Glimmer!"

"It is. Right, Daniel?"

"Uh, yes. Food production is, overall, ah, sufficient, or would be, to feed everyone. But it's a complicated issue, with politics and economics playing a part," Daniel replied while Jack made a last course change on the approach to Geneva Airport.

“Wow. And I thought the Horde had inefficient supply troops.”

“You can’t really compare a military supply system with the free market, Scorpia.”

“Why not? If you can’t feed your people, you’re doing something wrong, whether it’s an army or civilians.”

“It’s not that simple, Netossa.” Daniel was trying, but defending Earth’s economy wasn’t something he was good at. “It’s, uh… well, one thing is that most people don’t see people in other countries as their people.”

“And they let them starve because of that?” Netossa asked while Jack cut back on the shuttle’s speed and slowly came to a stop above the landing zone.

“No, well… they do help. It’s just, usually, not enough.”

“How can that be? I’ve checked the numbers we got from the Alliance. You’ve got enough resources to transport all the food and then some across your world - and that’s without the new shuttles or help from the fleet!” Netossa said.

“As I said, it’s a complicated issue. Most seemingly simple solutions created more problems, worse problems, along the line.”

“Yeah, Sam told us that,” Bow added. “If you just hand out food for free in a region, the local farmers will stop growing food of their own since it won’t pay, and so you might end up with even less food next season.”

Carter had done a better job at explaining than Daniel. That was sure. Jack sighed as he guided the shuttle down to the landing zone. Smoother than a helicopter and much easier to pilot.

“But you could just hand out enough food to cover the deficit, couldn’t you?” Spinnerella asked.

“That’s also complicated, but we try that.”

"You should try harder, then," Sweet Bee commented with a sniff. "How are you supposed to fight a war against a space empire if you can't even feed your own people? That obviously won't work!"

Jack was tempted to tell the princess about some examples from history, but the wind was picking up, and he had to be ready to compensate if the shuttle suddenly swayed. It was supposed to shrug off such stuff thanks to the artificial gravity generators, but a good pilot didn't blindly trust machines.

"Well, if we change the crops to be more efficient - I could make it so they can extract fertiliser from the air, for example - then everyone should be able to grow enough food in their country," Perfuma suggested.

"That, uh, might work, but I assume the corporations producing seed and fertilisers wouldn't be happy about losing their business," Daniel told them.

They would go screaming at their lobbyists. Which would be funny, actually. Jack snorted as the shuttle touched down on the tarmac. "And we've landed in Geneva," he said out loud. "Check if you've got all your gear before you leave the shuttle."

"Finally!" Her Honeyness exclaimed. "This took far too long!"

And it would take a bit longer, Jack knew. The Swiss had organised a reception for the delegation. Hell, they probably felt Sweet Bee was a kindred spirit, a fellow neutral or something.

Or they just wanted first dibs on offering to handle the princess's wealth.

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"...and this is where the United Nations meet to discuss Earth politics," Adora told Sweet Bee and Peekablue as they walked

through the hallway towards the meeting room prepared for them.

"We're aware of that. That is why we wanted to visit this country," Sweet Bee replied with a sniff. "We didn't come here for a guided tour. Or for weird food and drinks."

"Could have fooled me," Adora heard Catra mutter. "You certainly pigged out at the buffet."

Adora suppressed a snort. Her lover was right - Sweet Bee had tried all the food at the 'apéro' the Swiss had prepared. Quite enthusiastically, too.

"And we could speak to the leaders of a country not involved in the war," Peekablue added.

"But they're also unwilling to take a stand against the war!" Sweet Bee complained.

"That's the Swiss for you. They're just interested in your money." Jack shrugged.

"Well, they're a very small country," Bow said.

"That's even more of a reason to stand up for what's right!" Sweet Bee retorted. "Otherwise, the more powerful countries will attempt to roll over you."

"Demanding to use the Stargate without doing your part to protect it is not what I would call right," Glimmer told her with a glare.

"Of course, you wouldn't because you want more soldiers for your war! But that doesn't make it right!"

"And here we are!" Adora forced herself to smile widely as she opened the door to the meeting room and interrupted the bickering. "We'll be meeting the United Nations Secretary-General here."

“For all the good that will do,” Catra muttered next to her.

*****

“...and that’s how modern diplomacy on Etheria started.” Sweet Bee slowly nodded.

“Fascinating! So, your supra-national organisation grew out of a social event for princesses?” The Secretary-General - without his wife this time - chuckled.

Adora pressed her lips together so she wouldn’t lecture the man about the Princess Prom. It *was* a social event which, since it was open to all princesses and a neutral place during times of war, also served as a diplomatic event. Sweet Bee had not explained that correctly! But explaining that would be pointless - Sweet Bee certainly hadn’t taken well to Adora’s explanation that the Secretary-General wasn’t Earth’s ruler but also not a general.

“More or less, yes.” Sweet Bee slowly nodded. “Although it is only held every ten years, generally at least.”

This time, the Secretary-General laughed. “That wouldn’t work on Earth. We’re always busy at the United Nations.”

Earth certainly needed all the help it could get with its problems, in Adora’s opinion.

“Princesses are also always visiting each other, for various reasons,” Sweet Bee said.

“Like to annoy their neighbours who saved their asses,” Catra whispered.

Adora had to press her lips together again to keep from grinning.

“And, speaking of visiting your neighbour and friends…” Sweet Bee leaned forward a little. “Your United Nations controls Earth’s Stargate, right?”

“Ah.” The Secretary-General sighed and spread his hands a little. “That’s not entirely accurate. The situation with Earth’s Stargate is complex. It is essential for the war, which is in defence of all of Earth, of course. But at the same time, the Stargate belongs to all of Earth, regardless of whether or not they are part of the Alliance.”

“Exactly like on Etheria,” Sweet Bee said, nodding. “And yet, on Etheria, the Alliance controls the Stargate while it is under the control of the entire planet on Earth. Isn’t that correct?”

“Well, technically, that is true. But since three of the five permanent members of the Security Council are also members of the Alliance, the Alliance also effectively controls Earth’s Stargate.”

“Those five permanent members of your council can dictate the world’s policy, right?” Sweet Bee asked with narrowed eyes.

Adora pressed her lips together. The princess was quite well-informed about Earth - not that Adora and her friends would lie to her, of course. But she had to have sources in the Alliance.

The Secretary-General smiled. “I wouldn’t go that far. They have the power to veto a decision of the Security Council, but they do not rule the world.”

“But do they ban other countries from using the gate?”

“Access is, for now at least, limited to the Alliance and the five nations guarding the Stargate,” the Secretary-General told her. “The risk of an unprepared expedition or delegation running into Goa’uld forces is too high.”

Glimmer snorted, not quite triumphally. But she had a very wide grin on her face, Adora confirmed with a glance.

Sweet Bee, though, smiled. And it wasn’t the kind of fake smile you had when you didn’t want to let the other know you were annoyed. She was smiling like Glimmer. “Of course, that is, for a threat as the Goa’uld are presented at, quite reasonable. However,

there will be planets that are safe from such dangers. For example, planets that the Alliance has conquered."

"Liberated and secured," Adora corrected her. The Alliance didn't conquer territory!

"If a planet is secured, then, by definition, it poses no risks to visitors." Now Sweet Bee was sneering.

Adora clenched her teeth together. "You still have to remain alert. We're at war."

"You claim to be at war. I have yet to see any sign of it." The other princess sniffed.

"Maybe you should open your eyes then. Or ask Peekablue," Glimmer snapped.

"Earth is preparing for war," Peekablue spoke up, surprising everyone, or so it seemed - even Sweet Bee. "It does not seem to be mere pageantry to deceive us. If it were, the effort would vastly outweigh the benefits they might gain from it."

"Convincing everyone to go along with their policies seems worth such efforts - especially since naked force would be needed to enforce their will anyway, should their plan fail," Sweet Bee retorted.

"With the fleet in orbit?" Catra rolled her eyes. "You're delusional. Hell, the Alliance wouldn't even need soldiers; Adora could take on all of you at the same time with one hand tied behind her back, and she'd win. Easily."

"Catra!" Adora hissed. That was… well, probably not wrong, but not a nice or diplomatic thing to say!

Sweet Bee glared at Catra. For someone claiming to be neutral and against the war, she certainly seemed to loathe Catra and other former Horde members. "Even if that is the case, there would be no reason to hinder traffic between Etheria and Earth!

Didn’t you claim that you could detect any Goa’uld or Jaffa on either planet?”

The Secretary-General raised his eyebrows at that, for a moment at least, before he smiled politely again.

“We can’t block the Stargate for emergency traffic. That would hinder the war,” Glimmer said.

Sweet Bee scoffed. “A single trip would not take more than a few minutes - much less time than a supply transport such as the ones we observed takes. If you were so concerned about emergencies, you would not move so much material through the gate,” the princess said.

Peekablue nodded, and Adora had to wince a little - that excuse did sound a little weak to her as well. But just letting everyone travel between the two worlds sounded like a recipe for disaster to her. Adora and her friends had read up on what happened when countries suddenly had access to advanced or formerly prohibited technology, and in this case, it would probably go both ways. Smugglers on all sides, Tau’ri hunting for magitech - or sorcerers - to acquire or destroy them, all the Earth media, Etherians peddling exotic plants and other dangerous items… “We’ll need regulations and limits,” she said.

Glimmer shot her a betrayed look, but Adora didn’t falter. They couldn’t keep the other princesses from using the Stargate, so it was best to, ah, mitigate the damage. So to speak.

“So we’d be only able to use the Stargate - Etheria’s Stargate - at your convenience?” Sweet Bee sniffed again. “With your gratuitous permission, to be withdrawn whenever you fell like it?”

“Yes,” Glimmer told her in a flat tone. “The war takes precedence. We can’t risk an invasion of Etheria - or Earth - just to cater to your pride.”

“This is a matter of principles, not pride!” Sweet Bee protested.

Catra loudly snorted. Adora didn't quite follow her example, but she agreed with the sentiment - this was about Sweet Bee's pride and ego. Mostly. It was just unfortunate that she had a point about the Stargate belonging to Etheria. "Besides, you said that only Etheria and Earth were safe worlds, didn't you?" Catra cocked her head sideways.

"I said that they were safe by your own definition, not that they were the only planets safe to visit." Sweet Bee huffed.

Close enough, in Adora's opinion. She smiled.

"No planet with a Stargate is entirely safe from invasion," Bow pointed out. "Anyone can dial in from anywhere in the galaxy. The measures we've taken reduce the risk of an invasion, but every team that is sent out to another planet runs the risk of being captured and then taken over so they can use their codes - and bodies - to sneak back through the gate."

And gather intel about Alliance plans and operations.

"And then attempt to secure the Stargate for the main force," O'Neill added.

"But that risk can be neglected when we are merely talking about travel between Etheria and Earth," Peekablue spoke up again, smiling in a slightly smug way.

Adora nodded. If they had to fear Goa'uld infiltrators on either planet, then… well, then having Sweet Bee and her friends travel back and forth would probably not change anything.

"Earth itself isn't entirely safe for Etherians." Glimmer was still frowning. "Don't blame us if you get stoned or burned as a witch."

"Or blame the rest of Earth." O'Neill smiled. "That is if the United Nations actually accepts such a deal, mind you. We're just talking hypothetically here."

“I doubt that the United Nations will refuse,” the Secretary-General said. “The majority of the General Assembly will support it, in my opinion.” He spread his hands again. “Of course, some member states will be concerned about, ah, magic and sorceresses, but most will be looking forward to receiving visitors from Etheria - and visiting themselves.”

“As we are,” Sweet Bee declared.

“Just keep an eye on all those visitors,” Catra spoke up. “Some might be fanatics in disguise. Or spies and saboteurs. Or just thieves.”

“Are you accusing sovereign kingdoms of abusing their birthright to send criminals through the gate?” Sweet Bee glared at her.

Adora’s love grinned. “Yes.”

“Well, yeah, that kind of stuff is par for the course for many countries on Earth. We always have spies in our delegations.” O’Neill shrugged. “And, of course, there have to be strict regulations about animals and plants. Wouldn’t want to grow a haunted forest in a suburb by accident. That would ruin the property values, you know?”

“What?” Sweet Bee stared at him.

But Perfuma nodded. “Yes! We can’t endanger the local ecosystems by introducing alien plants and animals. That could cause untold disasters!”

“You’d know what you’re talking about.” O’Neill grinned as Pefuma blushed.

“I said I am sorry!”

The Secretay-Geneal raised his eyebrows but didn’t ask for more details.

Sweet Bee sniffed. “Well, for now, we can agree to limit travel to Earth and Etheria - provided we can confirm that the Goa’uld do represent such a threat to the Galaxy.”

“Just talk to the Tok’ra and you’ll be convinced in no time,” Catra told her.

Sweet Bee frowned, then turned to the Secretary-General. “So, since everyone is in agreement, we can formalise this.”

“Well, we’ll need a vote by the General Assembly and, of course, also the agreement of the Security Council,” he replied. “Although, especially with the support of the Princess Alliance for it, I don’t see why this would be rejected.”

“Well, unless the Alliance wishes to betray the lofty principles they claim to defend, this should be a formality quickly dealt with, then.” Sweet Bee smiled smugly.

O’Neill laughed, and the Secretary-General looked a bit ruefully.

Sweet Bee frowned again, her eyes narrowing.

Glimmer snorted. “You don’t have any experience with Earth politics, do you?”

“What do you mean?”

Adora’s friend smiled widely as she started to explain how long it would take for such an agreement to be ratified - in the best case.

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Cheyenne Mountain Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

The beeping noise of her computer interrupted Samantha Carter’s lab session with Entrapta.

“Oh? Are the Tok’ra arriving early?” Entrapta asked, looking up as her hair tendrils kept adjusting the latest experiment.

“I don’t think so - the gate room would have called us in that case,” Sam answered as she walked over to check.

“Too bad. Anise would be a great help here, I think.”

Sam nodded, but her reply died on her lips as she skimmed the message on her screen.

It was a report from the spy bot network. They had found a concentration of Goa’uld ships. Not too close to PZ -921, but close enough to threaten it.

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Educational Issues Part 6

Cheyenne Mountain Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"The recon drones have detected a Goa'uld fleet?"

"Yes, sir." Samantha Carter noted that, as usual, General Haig showed no reaction while General Hammond narrowed his eyes just a little, and General Petit's smile thinned a bit. General Li nodded, and General Sidorov…

…jumped up from his seat. "A Goa'uld counter-offensive in response to your attack on one of their planets!"

"But it's nowhere near Earth. The closest allied forces are on PZ-921, and even that is a week's flight at standard Goa'uld speed away," General Hammond retorted.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded with a wide smile. "Our spy bots have done such good work! They've spread out over a significant part of the area near PZ-921, in addition to the other areas they're expanding into, of course - the planned expansion of the network is proceeding on schedule, but we managed to increase production of the spy bots to allow focused additional expansion. I would show you the network, but Sam told me that we can't share that information with Stargate Command since this is Alliance intel. Sorry!"

Sidorov glared at her, but even Entrapta had learned not to take that seriously. General Li merely nodded.

"Of course. We're here as representatives of Stargate Command, not our home countries, which are members of the Alliance," General Petit remarked. "But I assume you are informing us of this because you need to use the Stargate in response to this information?"

"Yes." Sam nodded. "We need to contact the Tok'ra and inform them about this so they can direct their information-gathering operations towards this new development." Unless they hadn't done so already - the Tok'ra kept their spy network a secret from their allies, citing security reasons.

"You don't have the authority to make an official request to Stargate Command, Captain Carter!" Sidorov snapped.

"But I do," Entrapta replied. "I think, at least. I am a princess, and while you don't have princesses, it's a high rank in the Princess Alliance - we don't really have many higher ranks unless you count queen or commander, but that's Glimmer, or Supreme Commander, and that's Adora. Oh! If I can't ask you, I can just call Adora and have her ask you! We already informed the others, but I didn't know we had to ask them to ask you to call our allies."

"I think no one doubts that you can speak for the Alliance in such a matter," General Haig told her.

"Unless it's about experiments, yes," Entrapta nodded. "Glimmer told me that I need to pass the request for dangerous experiments through her and Bow. Or Sam. But Sam's here, and this isn't a request for interesting volatile samples, which we would examine and experiment with in space anyway, so an explosion wouldn't really threaten Earth."

General Haig still didn't show a reaction, but General Hammond winced, and General Petit's smile looked very strained now.

"So… can we call the Tok'ra?" Entrapta beamed. "We can ask if Anise wants to visit early, too!"

Was that a wince from Haig?

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"...and we stand here, representing neutral, peace-loving kingdoms of Etheria, hoping that we may find like-minded realms on Earth to forge closer ties through trade and…"

Catra tried not to roll her eyes at Sweet Bee's speech. It wasn't as if it mattered - the Secretary-General had predicted that the General Assembly would welcome the proposal to open the Stargate between Earth and Etheria for non-Alliance-related travel, and Catra didn't think he was wrong. The nations that were denied advanced technology by the Alliance would jump at the chance to get a trade partner on Etheria this way. And to send spies to the planet, of course. They couldn't stop it, not unless the Alliance simply took over the Stargates and banned everyone else from using it. And that was politically unfeasible - even Glimmer, who really wanted to do it, agreed with that.

At least it would take a while until there was an agreement. And some nations - those who persecuted witches and gay people - were unlikely to be able to make a deal. And the Alliance diplomats might be able to play some games and stretch things out some more. Play some of the supposed neutrals against each other, see if they could undermine Sweet Bee's support base on Etheria… Catra frowned. If she had done that at the Princess Prom instead of focusing on Adora, maybe…

She shook her head and pushed the thought away. Speculating like this was pointless. She had changed - and for the better. Everyone had changed, she added to herself as she glanced at Adora and the others.

"...and so we remain hopeful that you'll decide to open trade and diplomatic relations with our kingdoms."

Sweet Bee bowed as she - finally! - finished her speech.

The Secretary-General thanked her and started his own speech.

Catra was tempted to use some of the unofficial lessons learned in Horde training. Like how to feign attention while all but napping in

pointless lectures. But Adora would know, and her lover was already stressed by this whole affair. Well, partially, that was Adora's own fault. If she had told Sweet Bee to take a hike… OK, that would have caused trouble as well. And Adora would have felt terrible about it - betraying the ideals of the Alliance, hypocrisy, blah blah.

Catra watched the Chinese and Russian delegates. They were smiling widely - well, for Chinese and Russians. But other delegates were scowling. Mainly from the countries where magic was illegal. India's ambassador, of course, wasn't amongst them - he was beaming like Entrapta faced with an interesting and dangerous piece of First One technology. Well, the only reason that India hadn't yet managed to join the Alliance was because its government had split over the question of whether or not She-Ra was a goddess in their religion, so until that was settled, their government was paralysed. And they still had that terrorism problem that had led to the attack when Adora had brought magic back.

Well, Catra hoped they settled that soon - and stopped bothering Adora about it.

*****

'Alright. I think we have to cut this whole trip short since we just got intel about a Goa'uld fleet massing near the first world we liberated in the war, and we have to return to Stargate Command. So sorry!'

That was what Jack O'Neill would like to say, but he couldn't. Well, he could, but it would be pointless. Actually, it would be worse than pointless - Sweet Bee and Peekablue would jump at the chance to claim this was another attempt to use the war as an excuse to undermine their trade deals in the making or whatever they were hashing out in the meeting room next to theirs with the delegates from Russia and China.

"Russia *and* China!" he muttered. "That's a fine mess!" Of course, he hadn't really thought that they could keep Sweet Bee from making contact with their 'trusted partners' in Stargate Command, but the Russians and Chinese were far too prepared for this - information about Sweet Bee and her trip had to have been leaked prior to today.

Catra, sitting across from him, snorted. Of course, she had overheard him - her ears were twitching. "That's not because of anything we did - Sweet Bee decided to meet with them."

"Probably because Russia and China already have access to the Stargate, so they can't be easily blocked by the Alliance on Earth. She's got good chances to get a working trade deal out of this," Glimmer added with a scowl. "She also can play up how similar her kingdom is to them, both playing second fiddle to a vastly superior military."

Jack nodded. In hindsight, having the five permanent members of the Security Council taking control of Stargate Command (and blocking everyone else) but then taking effective control of it for the Alliance might not have been that smart. Sure, they couldn't let everyone meddle - having a 'Command Council' with five generals was a nightmare for anything serious - but it certainly didn't make Russia or China happy. Or anyone else outside the Alliance.

"Well… that's just obvious diplomacy, right?" Adora shrugged with a slightly strained smile. "She's annoying and rude and obstinate…"

"...a real pain in the ass!" Catra cut in with a grin.

Adora frowned at her but didn't contradict her. "...but she's an experienced diplomat."

Daniel cleared his throat. "I would think that most experienced diplomats would be, well, more diplomatic?"

That was a good point. Jack nodded in agreement.

Glimmer nodded as well.

“Her ego can’t handle not getting everything she wants,” Catra said. “So she is rude to compensate.”

“Speaking from experience?” Glimmer asked with a sly grin.

Catra scoffed at her.

“Well, if she had asked nicely, we would have been more, ah…” Adora trailed off.

“Accommodating?” Bow asked.

“Yes.”

“Someone learned a new word today!” Catra grinned again, and Adora rolled her eyes at her.

“Would you have been? Or would you just have been more polite in turning her down?” Jack asked. He knew how politics worked. Countries had interests, not friends.

“The Alliance agreed that gate travel had to be restricted to military needs,” Glimmer told him.

“And when you asked her for help during the war, she refused,” Catra added.

“Why should she benefit from what we fought and bled for?” Glimmer retorted.

“Technically, we discovered the Stargate after the war,” Bow pointed out.

Jack suppressed the urge to award him a point. Best not to provoke the magic princess.

“And that started another war,” Glimmer said with a scowl. “Which she is sitting out again.”

“But she’s right that the Stargate belongs to all of Etheria,” Adora said. “She could be nicer about it, but she’s right. And Peekablue fought in the Horde War. Just not the whole war.”

Glimmer scoffed again, muttering something unflattering, and Jack felt a bit torn. If the Goa’uld were aiming for your planet, it was all hands on deck. If you could fight, you fought. But he had known good soldiers who just couldn’t take it any more during a war - for no fault of their own. Peekablue might be like them. Might - it wasn’t as if Jack could tell. “Still, making enemies is not a good long-term strategy,” he said instead.

Glimmer, as expected, agreed.

Catra also nodded, flashing her fangs. “Payback’s a bitch, as you say on Earth. See if we do anything for her in the future. Her kingdom will be dead last in the queue for the Stargate.”

Adora, also just like Jack expected, frowned. “We’re not going to be so petty as to punish her kingdom just because she has been rude, are we?”

“She would deserve it,” Glimmer objected. Then she sighed. “But she’d twist that into another attack on the Alliance.”

“So?” Catra stretched like… like a cat. If Jack tried to do the same, his back would break, even with magical healing having restored his flexibility.

“And that means more diplomatic problems,” Glimmer told her. “Dad’s still dealing with Swift Wind’s… antics.”

Adora winced as if that were her fault. “Sorry.”

Catra rolled her eyes.

“International politics,” Jack commented. “Such a pain in the ass if you can’t just shoot problems.”

“Or princesses,” Catra added.

“Catra!” Adora glared at her. “We’re not the Horde.”

“Yeah. But Sweet Bee would have never dared to mouth off to the Horde,” Catra said.

“That’s not the point. We are better than the Horde. We won’t use violence to cow the other kingdoms,” Adora said.

She was completely sincere. Jack knew it. But so did Sweet Bee - Jack was sure of it. Well, anyone would know it after spending a bit of time with Adora; the girl simply was too honest for her own good. And a lousy liar.

“We still should do something to get back at Sweet Bee,” Catra objected.

“That would be petty,” Adora repeated herself.

“But oh so satisfying, right?” Catra shot back.

Jack nodded. “Yes.”

“Jack! We’re not going to risk a diplomatic incident because someone else was rude for a change!” Daniel protested.

“Well, it usually worked for me,” Jack defended himself. At least, it worked more often than not. Probably.

“I think that is in dispute. But if it were true, wouldn’t that be a good reason not to react to Sweet Bee’s rudeness?”

Daniel had a good point. Not that Jack would acknowledge it. Instead, he clapped his hands. “So, any bets whether Perfuma and Scorpia finish their talk before Sweet Bee and Peekablue do?”

“They’re just talking with a few environmental activists,” Bow said. “They’re not negotiating interstellar trade deals.”

“So, you think they’ll be done first, OK. Anyone else?” Jack grinned.

“I didn’t say I’d bet on it!”

“All bets are final!” Jack retorted.

“We didn’t even say what we bet!” Bow protested.

“Yeah, that was really careless of you.” Jack grinned. The kid was trying, but he had a lot to learn until he cold hold his own.

Catra nodded. “Yeah. Shame on you.”

“Catra!”

“Jack!”

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Adora laughed. A little - Jack was a bit mean to tease Bow like that, and the bet wasn’t really that funny. Catra chuckled, but that was to be expected. Still, it wasn’t really a laughing matter or situation. Sweet Bee making a deal with Russia or China - or both, or another country - could complicate things enormously. What if they made an alliance, and say, Russia or China wanted to shift troops to her kingdom? They had a lot of soldiers, and that might make other kingdoms feel threatened no matter how much Sweet Bee claimed that she didn’t want a war.

Could the Alliance stop them from moving soldiers through the Stargate? Well, they certainly could, on both sides of the gate, but should they? Sweet Bee was a sovereign princess, and Russia and China were sovereign nations. And part of Stargat Command. And the Alliance would have soldiers from Earth on Etheria sooner or later, for training and familiarisation at least.

Doing something but banning others from doing the same was hypocrisy. Even if there were good reasons for it, Adora felt bad about that. Of course, it was unlikely to begin with. It wasn’t really practical for either country to send troops through the gate - not in numbers that would be effective. The supply issues were too big; even the Alliance couldn’t really rely on the Stargate to

supply their troops in anything but a supplemental capacity. Of course, the United States had plans to improve that, but the easier you made it to transport freight through the Stargate, the harder you made it to defend it.

And the real issue, even though no one had mentioned it yet, was magic, not soldiers. Sweet Bee didn't have close ties to Mystacore, but sorceresses were free to move to her kingdom. And if the Russians or the Chinese set up an embassy there…

"What are you brooding about?" Catra interrupted her thoughts.

Adora looked up. Bow was still protesting that he never agreed to a bet, and Jack continued to claim that he had made outrageous wagers. And Daniel was trying to stop Jack. Glimmer seemed amused, Sea Hawk wasn't helping with his suggestions, Mermista shook her head, Frosta was giggling and… Oh. Spinnerella looked a bit anxious. Was she thinking the same things Adora was?

And now she had noticed Adora's glance and looked even more anxious. Adora grimaced.

But then, her friend sighed and straightened. "I think Sweet Bee honestly feels threatened," she said. "Seen from the outside, we might have seemed to act a bit, well… arrogantly, after the war."

Right. Spinnerella and Sweet Bee had been a couple for a time; Adora remembered hearing about that. But that had been a long time ago. Still, she would know Sweet Bee the best.

"We just did what was needed to start rebuilding. We aren't threatening them!" Glimmer protested.

"Even if you might want to," Catra added, grinning at Glimmer, which wasn't helping.

"But, well…" Spinnerella sighed again.

Netossa was still studying her tablet but now looked up and patted her wife's shoulder.

“I know we aren’t threatening them - only we are, in a way, you know?” Spinnerella smiled weakly. “We’re the strongest power on Etheria, even without the fleet. With the fleet… well, if we wanted to conquer the planet, we could. Easily.”

“Horde Prime thought the same,” Adoa pointed out. “He was wrong.”

“He was facing you and the Alliance, not some pacifist princess whose only power is to fly,” Catra said with a scoff.

That was true - flying wasn’t a very powerful, ah, power when people could use spaceships and shuttles. Or flyers. Or aeroplanes and Death Gliders. But it wasn’t the point. Taking Etheria was much harder than it might seem.

“We could crush her kingdom, and she couldn’t stop us. And Peekablue could only watch helplessly,” Netossa said. “The best intel is worthless if you don’t have the forces to act on it. The difference in power is too big. All the elemental princesses? And the biggest, richest kingdoms? With experienced troops? And the remains of the Horde?”

“We aren’t a threat to her kingdom,” Frosta cut in.

“But we could be,” Bow said. “And everyone knows it.”

“But she can trust us not to abuse our power,” Adora protested. That wouldn’t be right. She-Ra was a protector, not a conqueror!

“Sweet Bee is, well… she doesn’t easily trust people,” Spinnerella said.

“Smart of her,” Catra muttered.

Adora winced.

“I wouldn’t call insulting people who can easily crush you smart. Or countries,” Jack said.

“If we crushed her in response, we’d be as bad as the Horde!” Adora blurted out. Then she glanced at her lover. Catra didn’t react, but Adora still felt bad for reminding her of, well, the Horde. “We’d never do that!”

“And Sweet Bee is aware of that,” Spinnerella said. “She isn’t a fool. But… She is proud.”

“Like a princess,” Jack commented.

“Yes,” Spinnerella nodded at him, which seemed to surprise him for a moment. “Ruling Princesses are supposed to be equal in rank. Of course, they’re not equal in power, but before the Princess Alliance, the difference wasn’t as large as it’s now, and if you started a war, there was always the threat of a rival kingdom attacking you while you were fighting on another front to deter it.”

“There were alliances, but not on the scale of the Princess Alliance, and when rulers changed, alliances often changed as well. But that changed when the Horde attacked,” Bow said. “Now we’re the biggest power on Etheria.”

“And Sweet Bee doesn’t like it,” Spinnerella said. “It hurts her pride.”

“Tough,” Catra commented.

“Well, that’s kind of understandable,” Daniel said. “Many Americans share a similar sentiment - they were used to being the most powerful country on Earth, and now they aren’t any more. And many don’t like it.”

“The other countries like it, though,” Catra pointed out.

Was that how the other kingdoms, the other princesses, saw the Alliance? Adora didn’t like that. But… “The President hasn’t been rude, unlike Sweet Bee,” she said.

“Because he wants something from us - mainly our tech and support,” Bow said. “Sweet Bee doesn’t want to fight in the war,

so she can't join the Alliance."

"If we let people like her join, reaping the benefits without fighting the Goa'uld, we will be swamped with such leeches." Glimmer shook her head. "That would be unfair towards the ones who actually fight and risk their lives in the war. The blowback from that could cripple our forces."

Adora nodded. And it was wrong to let others fight your battles. But it was also wrong to force people to fight if they didn't want to.

"In any case, by being rude and an annoyance, she challenges us, shows she isn't a pushover," Bow went on. "That raises her standing amongst the other princesses."

"It also shows we won't crush people for disagreeing with us," Adora said. "Or discriminate against them." That should prove their good faith. Eventually, at least.

"Even though it would feel good," Catra said with a grin.

Adora lightly swatted her thigh.

"So, everybody wins?" Bow smiled weakly.

Glimmer scoffed. "She's still rude and annoying."

"And a pain in the butt," Frosta added.

Adora nodded in agreement.

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Cheyenne Mountain Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

"Hi, Anise! Oh, and hi, Martouf!"

"Entrapta! Sam!"

“Greetings, Captain Carter, Princess Entrapta.”

“Hello, Anise. Martouf.” A step behind Entrapta, Samantha Carter greeted their friends.

“We heard about your situation and decided to visit earlier than planned,” Martouf smiled. “I hope this is not a bother.”

“Not at all,” Sam reassured him. “Quite the contrary.”

Martouf glanced at Anise, who was already looking at some of the data Entrapta had prepared, then turned his attention back at her. “That’s good to hear. How have you been doing?”

“We’ve made a lot of progress, given the circumstances, although we’re still far from finishing our current projects.”

“Ah.” Martouf nodded. Sam expected him to say something more, but he didn’t.

“Let’s go to our lab,” Sam told him. She suppressed a wince - this felt awkward. Like meeting an ex too soon after a breakup. And yet, they had never had a relationship in the first place. Not Sam and Martouf. Only Jolinar and Martouf.

“Yes! We can work better there!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “And once our friends get back, you can tell Sweet Bee and Peekablue that the Goa’uld are dangerous.”

“Yes.” Martouf nodded. As they started to leave the gate room, he added: “I must confess I am curious about them. We were already aware that Etheria is not unified, but given their recent history, I would have expected that to have changed.”

“Earth has not united either,” Sam pointed out as they approached the lift. The two Chinese soldiers standing guard there didn’t react, but Sam was sure they were paying close attention.

“As I understand it, all the relevant powers are working together to fight the Goa’uld,” Martouf said.

The Colonel would make a quip about Russia and China, perhaps India as well, Sam knew. Or about not relevant powers joining to appear relevant. “I wouldn’t say that. Alliance membership is mostly limited because of politics.” Limited to countries that the Etherians deemed ethically acceptable, but to state that - and how ironic it was that absolute monarchies had higher standards than democracies when it came to alliances - would be impolite. Especially within earshot of the Chinese guards.

“Ah.”

“Yes!” Entrapta chimed in - fortunately, only after the lift had already started moving. “When it comes to ground combat, the armies of most of the countries on Earth would actually be sufficiently effective. But we can’t trust some of them, and it’s not OK to use them as cannon fodder to weaken them and the Goa’uld because if we did that, people wouldn’t trust us. That’s what Hordak and Catra said, at least, and it seems a sound analysis based on the available data.”

Sam winced. It was blunt but true. And she could imagine the two former Horde leaders saying this.

Anise nodded. “I concur.”

“Yes, it sounds quite plausible,” Martouf added. “Which means that Earth and Etheria are facing similar situations with internal dissent complicating the situation.”

“Yes,” Sam confirmed as they stepped out of the lift. From a certain point of view, at least.

“Let’s hope that the Etherian dissidents will listen to us,” Anise commented. “It would be disastrous if they underestimated the Goa’uld’s danger.”

“I don’t see why they would refuse to accept facts and evidence,” Entrapta said. “Our data proves our statements.”

“Not everyone is open-minded enough to change their views based on new data,” Sam told her friend. “Not even all scientists have an easy time with that.”

“But that’s the core of science!” Entrapta protested as they entered Sam’s lab. “If you ignore the data, you’re not a scientist!”

Anise nodded in agreement. “And you would be a fool to ignore facts.”

“Unfortunately, many people prefer to ignore reality rather than accept that they might be wrong,” Martouf said.

Sam had met more than a few of those people. Full of prejudice and pride. “What must not be, cannot be,” she muttered as she closed the door.

“Exactly,” Martouf said. “Which, incidentally, is a weakness many Goa’uld share.”

“Anyway,” Entrpata spoke up after a moment. “Here’s the rest of our data. Look at this!”

In the middle of the room, a holoprojection of a star system appeared. Entrapta’s hair tendrils flicked over a keyboard, and the projection zoomed in on a formation of Goa’uld ships - half Ha’taks, half Al’kesh and Tel’taks.

“The system isn’t claimed by any System Lord, as far as we know,” Sam added - though the Tok’ra already knew that.

“We’ve checked. We don’t know any gate addresses for this system either,” Anise said. “We haven’t received any notification from our spies about this, but since communication is dangerous, we might still receive more information about this.”

“We’re trying to crack their encryption to identify the ships, but they aren’t communicating a lot,” Entrapta said. “Or if they do, it’s through secure channels such as a Stargate on a ship and

directed short-range comms. And if we order the spy bots closer, they might be detected. So, that is a bit of a challenge."

"That is a quite unusual level of security for a System Lord," Martouf said. "An unclaimed system? Comm silence? Few would go to such lengths."

"Unless they are planning something underhanded." Sam nodded. "Like when Apophis was trying to frame Sokar."

"This could be a second attempt by Apophis, though I would assume that he would first want to find out what went wrong with his plan. Heru'ur… generally is blunter. He might want to keep it secret that he lost a planet, but he has to expect that whoever amongst his enemies took the planet will announce it anyway. And it could be Sokar's doing, though we don't know if he is aware of Apophis's plans for him." Martouf sighed. "We don't have a spy at Sokar's court. Not yet."

"So we need more data!" Entrapta summed up.

*****

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

Sweet Bee looked happy when she came out of the meeting room, Catra noticed. Of course, she would also be smiling even if the negotiations had completely broken up right after starting since she would have to keep up appearances, but the smile looked genuine. The smiles of the Russian and Chinese delegates, on the other hand, were too polite to tell if they were genuine.

Catra had hoped that the Tau'ri tendency to drag things out for months over details would have frustrated the princess. Then again, judging by some Alliance meetings Catra had taken part in, maybe Sweet Bee had expected that. Or they actually had reached an agreement… No. That wasn't how things were done on Earth.

Peekablue, on the other hand, looked as absent-minded as usual - his polite smile not matching his unfocused eyes. But that was probably a ruse, Catra reminded herself. The prince was paying much more attention to his surroundings than one would expect at first glance. If she had had to deal with him during her time as the Horde leader…

"We have come to a preliminary agreement to continue our negotiations," Sweet Bee announced. "I trust that the Alliance won't attempt to block our peaceful diplomatic meetings."

We should send you to a Goa'uld planet and leave you stranded there, Catra thought. See how you like your 'peaceful diplomacy' when the snakes come to burrow into your body. But that would probably help the Goa'uld, which would make the war harder. And Adora wouldn't like it.

Since they were in public - sort of; there was a photographer, but he was apparently working for the United Nations, not the press, and the Secretary-General was smiling at the idiot with other diplomats - Catra stuck to flashing her fangs in an insincere smile while the Chinese delegate - what was his name again? Something weird - repeated what Sweet Bee had said using slightly different sentences.

"The Alliance always supports peaceful diplomacy - as long as it won't hinder the efforts to defeat the Goa'uld and free millions of humans suffering in slavery," Glimmer announced with a toothy smile as soon as they had finished.

Adora nodded emphatically. "Yes. We won't sacrifice people for trade negotiations."

That should do well with the press, Catra thought. Even though she was sure that a lot of Earth's leaders would be perfectly fine with that trade. At least in private. They let people starve for profit, after all.

"Of course not." Sweet Bee's smile looked as sincere as Glimmer's.

Peekablue, though, nodded. “Yes. We’re aware of the cost of a war.”

Then the Secretary-General started a hopefully short speech about peace and trade and reaching out that had Catra struggle not to yawn. It was past time to go and meet the Tok’ra - and then push Sweet Bee’s butt back through the Stargate. Preferably with a kick.

And Peekablue as well.

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Cheyenne Mountain Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 22nd, 1999

“Colonel O’Neill!”

“Anise. Martouf.” Jack O’Neill forced himself to smile as he greeted the Tok’ra. Anise looked far too happy to see him, in his opinion. So happy, indeed, that he felt the urge to check if she had drawn blood somehow while everyone shook hands and exchanged platitudes.

“... these are Princess Sweet Bee and Prince Peekablue. Sweet Bee, Peekablue, these are the Tok’ra Anise and Freya and Martouf and Lantash,” Adora introduced their visitors to each other.

Peekablue was openly staring at them - was he trying to spot the snakes inside them? Could he use his magic to look into people? That would make him even more dangerous than Jack had thought. And a lot more useful as well, of course.

“I see,” the prince said, nodding slowly.

Had that been a joke? Jack couldn’t tell; the Etherian prince always looked as if he was high. Jack blinked. His comparison to David Bowie in the 70s might actually closer to the mark than he had thought.

“You see?” Martouf asked.

“I have the gift of Farsight.”

“Ah.” The two Tok’ra exchanged glances.

“And what does that do?” Anise was blunt as ever.

“It lets me see,” Peekablue told her, sounding absolutely serious.

Jack grinned at Anise’s reaction. That had definitely been a joke! If the prince were not with Her Annoying Honeyness, Jack would probably like the guy.

Anise sniffed. “And you think the Goa’uld aren’t a danger to everyone.”

“We wish to verify what the Alliance has told us about them from independent sources,” Sweet Bee told her. “But there don’t seem to be unbiased sources.”

“Because the Goa’uld destroy or enslave everyone they can. They are as dangerous and evil as you’ve heard - or more so,” Anise said with a scowl.

Martouf nodded. “The Tok’ra have been fighting them for thousands of years. Some of us are former Goa’uld who managed to see the light and deserted them. We know their very souls. They are cruel, vain, greedy and willing to betray even their closest kin for more power. Their cruelty knows no bounds.”

Laying it on a little thick, Marty, Jack thought. But then, the Etherians might lap that up.

While the two snakes started to tell Tales of the Goa’uld, uncut edition, Jack looked around. The lab looked like it always looked - cluttered despite Carter’s meticulous organisation, with too much stuff that you shouldn’t touch spread around everywhere.

And Carter herself was typing on her laptop, with Entrapta looking over her shoulder. Working hard, harder than anyone else. As usual, he thought. She was really a model officer. Far too good for…

He caught himself smiling in a non-professional or diplomatic way and quickly schooled his features.

*****

"...and then Ra had the entire planet bombed from orbit." Martouf - no, that was Lantash speaking, Adora realised even though they hadn't changed their tone - pointed at the records Sam's projector displayed in the middle of the lab. "He punished an entire world for the actions of their leader - a leader of his choice who had subjugated and enslaved the population."

She glanced at the recording being shown and winced. A formation of Ha'taks was shooting their cannons in orbit, Al'keshs swooping down, dropping bombs… and explosions on the ground. Many, many explosions.

Sweet Bee looked… struck. Her lips were trembling. And Peekablue… Had closed his eyes and was trembling. His lips were pressed together, forming a thin blue line. Oh, no - he must be suffering a flashback, as Earth called it! "Please stop the recording!" she blurted out.

"But we've just started," Anise objected. "This is just the part covering Ra's forces - we're about to show footage from the ground."

"No, we aren't," Adora told her, getting up. "Stop it, Entrapta!"

"OK!" Entrapta looked a little confused, but her hair reached out, and the holoprojection froze for a second, then faded out.

"What's the…? Oh." Bow grimaced; he would know about the problem from his dads, Adora remembered. "Sorry, we should have warned you."

“Warned us?” Sweet Bee blinked, then glanced at Peekablue and Gasped. “Peekablue!” She reached over and wrapped her arm around his shoulder.

“I’m OK,” he said. He was obviously lying, though - he still hadn’t opened his eyes. He returned Sweet Bee’s hug, but it looked like he was clinging to her as she gently sat him down on the ground.

“Definitely not OK,” Catra commented in a low voice.

Anise was still frowning, but Martouf leaned towards her and whispered something which made her blink.

Well, that seemed to have been handled. That left… No, a glance confirmed that not even Jack was about to make a joke. He was just standing there and looking awkward.

Like almost everyone else, actually. Even Entrapta wasn’t looking confused any more, though she was talking to Sam in a low voice. And Sam looked uncomfortable.

Adora bit her lip - she shouldn’t pry. She really shouldn’t. It was rude. She should respect someone’s privacy. On the other hand, Entrapta was her friend, and, well, she was often confused by things others took for granted, and that made her vulnerable. Sam was Adora and Entrapta’s friend, but Adora had known Entrapta for much longer, and…

“She’s telling Sam that Hordak reacts differently,” Catra whispered.

Adora glanced at her lover. Catra wasn’t showing any reaction. She was even looking a bit bored - or trying to fake it.

Adora was about to tell her that she shouldn’t try to appear so distant, but then Peekablue opened his eyes.

And they were… She gasped. His pupils were so big, you couldn’t see the white of his eyes any more. And he wasn’t blinking.

Catra cursed next to her.

“What’s going on?” Glimmer asked.

“Flashback,” Jack replied.

“PTSD,” Sam added a moment later. “Post-traumatic stress disorder.”

“He is remembering what he saw during the war,” Bow said.

“Like a nightmare, just… without falling asleep first,” Netossa added.

“Quiet!” Sweet Bee hissed, still hugging the prince. “You’re not helping!”

For a change, no one snapped back as she used one hand to gently turn Peekablue’s head towards her face and started whispering to him.

Adora didn’t glance at Catra, and her lover didn’t tell her what the princess was saying. After a few very, very awkward minutes of silence, Peekablue closed his eyes and loudly sighed, then slumped over.

Sweet Bee hugged him a bit longer, then rose. “We’ll return to Etheria. We can continue this talk at a later date. Without such… demonstrations.”

“Alright!” Entrapta nodded.

“Let’s go back to the gate,” Jack said and walked towards the door. Sweet Bee and Peekablue got up and followed him. Adora watched them go. She should go with them to the gate, but… She couldn’t do anything to help them.

Instead, once the door closed behind them, she looked at her friends and her lover. “So… We’ve got a fleet to deal with?”

After a moment, Sam nodded. “Yes. You’ve seen the data we’ve gathered so far. Unfortunately, We still haven’t identified to which

System Lord it belongs."

"We've passed the information on. The Council will look into it," Martouf added. "But unless an operative of ours already knows about this, this will take some time."

"We're analysing their communication - as much as we can, at least - but there are a few problems we have to deal with, namely…"

As Entrapta continued to explain, Adora did her best to focus on the information they had already gathered. And not on the few nightmares she had since the Horde War had ended. She didn't want to remember them.

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"So, we hope that the Tok'ra can find out what's going on with that fleet, but better don't count on it. I bet we'll have to go there and take a look ourselves," the Colonel said. "But… not right now. I still have to do the paperwork for this visit." He stood and rolled his neck, then walked towards the door. "And that'll be a bitch. Because of a bitch."

"Jack!" Daniel gasped, following him out.

Samantha Carter refined from commenting, but she sighed as the door closed and cut off the Colonel's next comment.

"So… is that why Peekablue left the Alliance? The first princess Alliance, I mean. Because he couldn't see the war any more, and so couldn't fight any more?" Entrapta asked.

"It looks like it," Sam replied.

"Hordak doesn't act like that when he remembers."

She had told Sam that already. "PTSD expresses itself differently in people," Sam explained. So, Hordak suffered from it as well. He was still a former warlord who didn't really show too much

remorse, in her opinion. But Entrapta loved him. And, at least as far as Sam knew, he loved her. More importantly, she didn't think he would ever hurt Entrapta.

"Apparently." Her friend sat down on the edge of her desk - solidly bolted to the floor - and used her hair to stow some of their gear. "So, how do you fix that?"

Sam winced. "That's also different for everyone. Therapy can help." But some couldn't get better at all.

"We'll have to talk to Hordak about therapy then." Entrapta nodded. "And to Peekablue, I guess."

Sam winced again. 'We'? She didn't want to talk to Hordak about his trauma. But Entrapta was her friend and obviously expected her to do this. So, she nodded and forced herself to smile. "Alright."

"Great! We can travel back to Etheria with Peekablue and Sweet Bee! I'll tell the others!" Entrapta hopped down and was halfway to the door before Sam could react.

"Wait! We've got more urgent problems to deal with!"

Entrapta stopped, turned and cocked her head. "More urgent than dealing with such pain?"

That was… a good question. Sam didn't quite know how to answer it. And they had to wait for the Tok'ra to send word, anyway.

It looked like she'd have to talk about therapy with Hordak.

Great.

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The Therapy Question Part 1

Bright Moon, Etheria, January 22nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"I feel guilty."

Catra, lying on her back on their bed, rolled her eyes at Adora's comment and turned her head to glance at her lover. "It's not your fault. Stop being an idiot."

"You didn't even ask what I'm feeling guilty about!" Adora pouted.

Catra grinned in return. "I don't have to. You're always feeling guilty about stuff that's not your fault."

"Not always!" her lover protested.

Catra raised her eyebrows in response. "Name one example."

"Ah…" Adora closed her mouth and pouted again. "But I should have realised that Peekablue was suffering!"

"How?" Catra scoffed. "Not even Melog managed to find that out until he had his flashback." That was a good name for it. Much better than 'nightmare while being awake', or what Glimmer tried to come up with.

"But I knew that fighting in a war left you… hurting." Adora finished hanging up her and Catra's clothes - as if they didn't have maids for that in the palace! And the clothes would be collected and sent to the laundry in the morning anyway! - and sat down on the bed next to Catra. She was biting her lower lip, Catra noticed. "It's… many have nightmares."

"Yeah." That wasn't really new. Hell, Catra had nightmares as well. Not as many as back then, not since she had started sleeping in Adora's bed again, but still. And that was normal - she didn't know anyone who never had nightmares. "Everyone has nightmares. You don't have to fight in a war to get them."

“But it’s not the same! Peekablue was… He was trembling, and his eyes…” Adora shook her head.

Catra clenched her teeth for a moment. Yes, the stupid Prince had looked terrible. But that wasn’t Adora’s fault. “But you couldn’t know that he had the worst trauma,” she said, as gently as she could, while she sat up and slid behind her lover so she could wrap her arms around Adora’s waist.

“I should have!”

Catra rolled her eyes behind Adora’s back. “No, you couldn’t. Most people who go through traumatic experiences don’t suffer like he does.” At least not for over ten years. Someone would have told them if that was normal, right? Catra pushed the stupid thought away. “It’s not your fault that he had a flashback. You didn’t know and couldn’t know. He didn’t tell us, either.”

“Well, yes, but… I still feel guilty. I thought he was a coward for not fighting! I didn’t even consider that he might have had a good reason to stop fighting! That he couldn’t fight any more! That his magic power would have shown him so many horrible things…”

Catra tensed before she managed to force herself to relax. She was responsible for a lot of those things. If Peekablue had kept an eye on the war… No, he wouldn’t have. Not when just recordings of a Goa’uld attack caused such a reaction. He wouldn’t have tortured himself like that. She was sure of that. Pretty sure. Whatever. Adora was blaming herself, and Catra had to do something about that. “He didn’t tell us, so why would we suspect that? It’s his fault for not telling us. It’s like…” Think, idiot, think! “It’s like a food allergy. If you don’t tell people you are allergic to some food, it’s your own fault if they serve something that hurts you!”

“How much Earth television did you watch?” Adora asked, turning her head and shifting a bit around to frown at her.

“That was from the lecture about travelling to different planets and trying different food,” Catra defended herself. And there had been something about that.

“Ah.” Adora shook her head. “It’s not the same. We’ve been blaming him and Sweet Bee for not wanting to fight the Goa’uld even though the Goa’uld are a danger to everyone, but we didn’t know this!”

“Sweet Bee didn’t have any traumatic experience in the war.” The stupid princess had avoided the Horde War - Catra knew all princesses who had fought the Horde when she had been in command. She shifted around, lying across Adora’s lap, on her back so she could face her lover.

“She could have fought against Horde Prime’s invasion,” Adora retorted.

“Do you really think she wouldn’t have told us that, repeatedly, to get access to the gate?” Catra snorted.

“Ah…” Adora sighed. “I guess she would have.”

Catra nodded. “Absolutely.” The arrogant princess would have thrown that into their face at every opportunity.

“But she knows about Peekablue’s trauma. So, she knows how it happened.”

“So?” Catra narrowed her eyes.

Adora took a deep breath. Catra felt her arms tense around her shoulders and hip. “She would know that this could happen to her in the war.”

“That only makes her a coward,” Catra snapped. Countless people had fought anyway. OK, not all of them had had a choice or knew any better, but… She clenched her teeth again.

“Not everyone is cut out to fight.”

"She's a princess. If she's not willing to fight for her kingdom, she should step down!" Catra spat. "She owes her people that!"

Adora nodded. "But what… what if her people aren't in danger?"

"Because the Alliance protects everyone?" Catra scoffed again. "Then she should help us anyway."

Adora sighed and slowly nodded, but Catra had a feeling that her lover didn't quite agree.

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Cheyenne Mountain Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 23rd, 1999

"Colonel O'Neill, could you explain why the United Nations has sent a request to let a delegation composed of members of several non-governmental organisations visit Etheria?"

General Hammond hadn't lost his touch, Jack O'Neill noted to himself. The man's tone was polite, even slightly bored, his question innocuous, but his expression… Jack forced himself to smile. "I assume that's related to the meeting Perfuma had with them in Geneva."

"A meeting the Command Council wasn't informed of until now." Hammond frowned openly now.

"I think it was in our report," Jack defended himself.

"It was - I checked. 'Princess Perfuma was curious about the biosphere of Earth, and the Secretary-General referred her to a few specialists of his acquaintance'," Hammond quoted. He didn't quite slap the report down on his desk, but it came close. "Nothing about *an agreement to restore the Amazon rainforest with magic*."

Ah. "I didn't hear anything about that, sir," Jack said. Granted, he - and the others, including Perfuma as soon as she heard of it -

had been focused on Peekablue's nervous breakdown and then the whole business about the hidden Goa'uld fleet tok priority.

"Yes, General," Daniel bravely tried to help. "Specifics never came up, though Perfuma was talking about restoring the rainforest earlier in the day."

"And you didn't mention that either, Dr Jackson?"

Damn! Jack knew that face. Daniel was digging his heels in. "It was not relevant to the task we were given, General. We were to report about Sweet Bee's diplomatic mission," his friend said.

"I would think that it was clear that a foreign head of state planning to intervene in a nation on Earth, with possible repercussions for the entire planet, should have been reported."

"I didn't hear anything about an intervention." Daniel frowned. "Perfuma was merely interested in the possibility of using her magic to restore nature, and the Secretary-General referred her to several organisations with similar goals."

"Yes, General," Jack added. "If we can't trust the Secretary-General of the United Nations - of which Stargate Command is a part - then whom could we trust?"

And here came the glare. Jack had to work on his innocent act. "This isn't a time for jokes, Colonel. The CIA has warned us that there are questionable elements amongst the delegation."

"'Questionable elements'?" Daniel raised his eyebrows.

"Potential extremists, Dr Jackson. As you might be aware, there's some concern about extremists of various kinds acquiring magic to enforce their demands."

"Are you sure that was the CIA and not the United Fruit Company?" Daniel inclined his head. "Did they label Greenpeace as terrorists as well?"

"Well, they do oppose nuclear power, which probably means they'll oppose spaceships," Jack commented. "That will make it hard for them to blockade spaceship yards with their own spaceships, though."

No one laughed, and Daniel frowned at him.

"Greenpeace is actually an organisation under observation according to our sources," Hammond said,

Daniel blinked, then took a deep breath. "Of all the… What is going on? This is ridiculous!"

"It is the stance of the United States Government that the reckless use of magic by independent actors might endanger the entire planet, Dr Jackson." Hammond met his eyes. "I think that, thanks to your close acquaintance with the Etherians, you are aware of how dangerous magic can be."

Daniel had an incredulous expression for a moment before he scowled. "Thanks to our *close friendship* with the Etherians, we are aware that the odds of anyone on Earth being able to endanger the entire planet with magic are infinitesimally small. We don't have the tradition, knowledge and magitech to create anything like what the Etherians dealt with."

"We aren't only concerned about such threats, but also about magical diseases, invasive species - and the repercussions of…" Hammond glanced at another file. "...magical geoengineering and altering of regional ecosystems, especially with regard to the climate."

"Oh, now we're concerned about the climate, are we?" Daniel scoffed. "Ruining the ecosystems of entire countries was fine as long as it wasn't done with magic?"

"Dr Jackson." Hammond narrowed his eyes at him.

To Jack's relief, Daniel backed down. "Sorry, sir. But these concerns seem oddly specific and limited."

"Not the concerns about invasive species and magically altered diseases," Carter spoke up. "Those could be very dangerous."

"Perfuma is aware of that, though," Daniel retorted. "She wouldn't endanger us like that."

"And her new friends on Earth are as responsible?" Jack shook his head. "I'm not a biologist or a sorcerer, but we've all seen what magic can do, and it probably wouldn't take much to change a virus into the second coming of the Spanish Flu." He had done a report about that at the Academy once. Nasty stuff.

"That's just speculation," Daniel said. But he looked less confident now. "And Perfuma and the others will be aware of that. And they will likely have countermeasures for such incidents."

"Which they will, generously and selflessly, share with us," Jack said, not hiding his sarcasm. "Oh, I know they will," he said when Daniel opened his mouth. "But that'll be one more thing we'll depend on them for."

"Only until we get sorceresses of our own, Jack," Daniel said.

"Good luck with that," Jack muttered. The last thing he wanted was more pressure to study magic.

"In any case, the Command Council expects you to discuss these concerns with our allies," Hammond said.

"Yes, sir."

Great. More magic talk.

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Bright Moon, Etheria, January 23rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, Sweet Bee and Peekablue haven't contacted us yet to reschedule their meeting with the Tok'ra. If they ever do,"

Glimmer said, slowly looking at everyone at the table in the meeting room.

She sounded a bit… not smug. But… relieved? Adora wasn't quite sure. Adora herself certainly wasn't sad that she wouldn't have to face Sweet Bee and Peekablue right away. She still felt ashamed for her annoyance at them before she found out about Peekablue's issues.

"Let's hope that the talk they had with the Tok'ra was enough to convince them that the Goa'uld are a real threat," Mermista commented with a frown.

"I don't think Peekablue could go through another such talk," Perfuma said. "At least not if they have more such… records."

"Sweet Bee could do it herself," Adora pointed out. That would be the logical course of action.

"If she's interested in the truth, at least," Glimmer muttered. Louder, she said: "Anyway, we can just wait until they contact us again. We've got a more pressing problem to deal with."

"Yes!" Entrapta perked up. "Therapy!"

"No, I meant… what?"

What? Adora blinked. She wasn't the only one - pretty much everyone at the table was staring at Entrapta.

"Therapy?" Catra asked.

"Yes. I talked with Sam, and I confirmed it with some data we gathered on Earth, but overlooked until now, but therapy can help you deal with traumatic experiences. It's not always successful, though. But it shouldn't make things worse, I think. So, the logical course of action would be to do it." Entrapta nodded firmly.

"Good luck telling Sweet Bee and Peekablue that. If they don't believe us about the Goa'uld, they won't believe us about

therapy," Glimmer told her with a snort.

"Oh, I wasn't thinking about Peekablue - but he probably should get some therapy too, yes. Although Sam told me that the patient needs to want to get therapy or it won't really help, which is quite an interesting difference compared to other forms of healing, right?"

She wasn't thinking about Peekablue? Then who…? Oh! "You want us to get therapy?" Adora blurted out before she could stop herself.

"What?"

"That's stupid!"

"I don't need therapy!"

"We don't need therapy!"

"I'm doing fine!"

"What's therapy?"

"I'm not like Peekablue."

Adora looked at Catra. Her lover hadn't said anything, but she was glaring at Entrapta. And clenching her teeth, hard - Adora could tell from the way her cheeks twitched. She reached over to squeeze Catra's thigh and felt how tense the other girl was.

Entrapta looked confused - and taken aback - by the reactions of the others. "Therapy is a form of treatment that Earth scientists have developed to deal with trauma. And war - which we have gone through - is a commonly mentioned source of such trauma. And the symptoms of a post-traumatic stress disorder vary wildly, but nightmares are amongst them."

And everyone had had nightmares after the war, Adora was sure of that. Judging by the glances the others exchanged, they

remembered that as well. But she wasn't sure if those therapists she remembered from the shows and movies she had seen on Earth were scientists. They hadn't really seemed like scientists to her, but then, many of those shows and movies had been fiction.

"Earth did that? Without magic?" Mermista didn't quite sneer, but her expression was not really supportive.

"You can't use magic to, ah, cure trauma," Adora told her friends. She had looked quite thoroughly into that after the war, when Catra had had more frequent nightmares. And Adora as well, but that was another topic. In any case, everyone she asked - Glimmer and Castaspella - had been clear that there was no spell to deal with nightmares and guilt.

"My research shows that therapy is generally based on talking to specialists," Entrapta smiled as she explained, but she still looked confused by the reactions. And perhaps a bit afraid. "It helps, according to my data."

"Talk to a stranger?" Mermista frowned even more. "About what, exactly?"

"The experience that left you traumatised. And your feelings." Entrapta nodded. "It sounds fascinating, actually - the people on Earth have so much data about emotions."

"I bet they have," Catra mumbled.

"That sounds stupid!" Frosta declared. "Why should we talk to a stranger about that? Not that we need to, anyway, but there're a lot of secrets involved in the war - and there will be more secrets in this war. You can't just talk to a stranger about that!"

"Well, talking to a friend about your feelings could be… embarrassing," Sea Hawk said with an embarrassed smile. "Talking to a stranger might be easier."

He was glancing at Scorpia, Adora noticed. And Scorpia seemed embarrassed as well. What was up with that?

“Well, I’m fine. I don’t need to talk to anyone about that stuff,” Frosta said.

“Are you sure?” Perfuma looked concerned. “Talking to a friend helps; I know that. If you don’t want to talk to a stranger, you can talk to me.”

“I told you: I am fine!” Frosta retorted.

Now that sounded familiar. Adora glanced at her lover, but Catra was still sitting here, tense and more silent than expected. She wasn’t fine at all. And Adora didn’t think the rest of her friends were fine, either. There was no helping it; she had to do something. “I think it would be a good thing to talk about such things,” she said. Not talking about your feelings certainly wasn’t doing anyone any good. If only Adora and Catra had talked about their feelings for each other before everything had gone wrong…

Glimmer frowned at her, Adora saw, but Bow nodded. As did Netossa and Spinnerella. And Entrapta, of course. Mermista, though, crossed her arms over her chest and scowled, but Sea Hawk was whispering to her. Frosta mimicked her. Perfuma beamed at Adora, Scorpia smiled, and Catra… Rolled her eyes but didn’t scoff or make fun of her.

Well, that was a better reaction than Adora had feared.

“Even if we want to talk to a therapist, who could we trust?” Glimmer said.

“We can talk to a friend,” Perfuma repeated herself.

“Therapists are professionals with a code of ethics that requires them to keep their patients’ secrets,” Entrapta said. Probably quoting her data.

“That’s what they are supposed to do. But can we trust them to actually stick to it?” Glimmer shook her head. “And they would all be from Earth - we would depend on them. That’s… unbalanced.”

“We could ask for them to train our own therapists?” Perfuma suggested.

“They’ll want training in magic in return. And you know what Mystacore said about that.”

“Well, yes. But…”

Adora leaned back a little as the discussion shifted about how to get therapy. Things were looking up, it seemed.

“You’re going to therapy as well, you know,” Catra whispered. “We’re probably going to need two therapists for you alone.”

Or not.

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Bright Moon, Etheria, January 24th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“Sam! There you are!”

“Greetings, Captain Carter.”

“Hello, Entrapa. Hordak.” Samantha Carter nodded at her friend and her… partner as she stepped into their lab in the palace.

Entrapta’s smile turned into a wince. “I wanted to welcome you at the gate, but then the experiment with the new bot matrix hit a hitch, and we kinda lost track of time! I’m sorry!”

“It’s no problem,” Sam told her. “I know the feeling.” It had happened to her a few times as well, after all. The Colonel liked to claim that she intentionally lost track of time as an excuse, but that wasn’t true. Not really.

“Good!” Her friend beamed at her, then turned around to look at Hordak. “Science Buddy! We need to talk!”

“Yes?” Hordak cocked his head and slowly turned to face her. Compared to the other clones, he felt quite a bit more alien, Sam

noticed again. There was always some hesitation in his movements. Some stiffness. Maybe it was a lingering psychological effect from living in a crippled body for so long, even being restored to full health hadn't been able to overcome it. Not to mention that the circumstances of that process hadn't been deeply traumatic. And, speaking of trauma, Sam had to consider how to diplomatically breach the reason for today's visit…

"You need to get therapy!" Entrapta blurted out.

Sam suppressed a wince at her friend's bluntness - which she should have expected.

"Therapy?" Hordak looked confused.

"A treatment for trauma that Earth scientists have developed!" Entrapta beamed at him.

But Hordak scowled. "I do not require such treatment."

"Yes, you do!" Entrapta, completely unimpressed, nodded emphatically. "The data is conclusive. You've experienced traumatic events - lots of them that we don't need to go into now - and you're showing symptoms of post-traumatic stress disorder."

"I do not."

"You have nightmares," Entrapta pointed out. "That's a symptom."

"That is a normal reaction. Everyone has nightmares." Hordak shook his head and crossed his arms over his chest, raising his chin. "I am no different in that than anyone else."

"Well, yeah, but that doesn't mean you don't need therapy. It could mean that everyone needs therapy. Which I think would be the more plausible deduction, actually." Entrapta cocked her head to the side. "In any case, the Alliance is currently discussing how to get therapy. I think so, at least - some were not very receptive to the idea, but Adora supported it. And Catra as well, I think - she didn't protest, at least. And she's like you, kinda."

Sam's eyes widened. The princesses were planning to get therapy? That was… a huge surprise. And important information, she added with a pang of guilt.

Hordak scoffed. "Catra would agree to anything Adora proposes."

"Well, probably, yes. But that doesn't change the data or the conclusions."

Hordak didn't look convinced. "And what does this 'therapy' entail?"

"Well, according to my research, you basically talk with specialists about your feelings and problems until you feel better."

Sam cleared her throat. "It's a bit more complex than that. It's about dealing with traumatic experiences and memories by focusing on changing mental distortions and adapting coping strategies." Well, the most effective and common therapy for trauma did, at least according to her admittedly cursory research.

"I fail to see how this would work," Hordak retorted, glowering at her now.

"Well, that's because you don't know anything about this - we haven't researched this yet!" Entrapta smiled. "Once we know more, that'll change! That's why Sam's here!"

Sam blinked. She hadn't expected that - this was a misunderstanding! She wasn't a psychologist, much less a therapist! She was a physicist, not a shrink!

"Earth has tons of experience with that stuff - I found tons of material in our databanks! Everyone gets therapy there!" Entrapta went on. "Look!"

Her hair tendrils touched the keyboard behind her, and documents appeared on the big screen in the lab. And pictures. And clips from TV shows and movies. Most of them fictional, Sam realised with a sinking feeling.

“You see? It’s very common on Earth, which is logical given how many wars they have, and how many other traumatic experiences. Right, Sam?”

Sam winced. “Well, that’s… not entirely accurate…”

“No?”

“No?”

“Not everyone who needs therapy gets it,” Sam started to explain. Fortunately, her quick research had covered this, although not in real depth. “And while it generally helps, it’s not a perfect cure - far from it. Its effectiveness depends on many factors, and…”

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“...and so, people are kind of concerned about any plans to restore the rainforest.”

Catra snorted as O’Neill finished and shrugged before leaning back in his seat and nibbling on a finger sandwich. So, Earth was worried about Perfuma wanting to help them. Typical!

“‘People’?” Glimmer asked, raising her eyebrows.

“You know, the United Nations, the countries which include parts of the rainforest, various corporations involved in the agricultural business…” O’Neill shrugged. “Lots of people.”

“Lots of interest groups,” Daniel added with a scoff. “Although the countries that would be affected by Perfuma’s hypothetical actions are legitimately concerned.” He glanced around in Glimmer’s office. “We had hoped to talk to her about that, actually.”

“Well, she’s back in Plumeria or the Scorpion Kingdom,” Glimmer replied. “We had an Alliance meeting yesterday, and people needed a break.”

And Perfuma was probably trying to persuade more of their friends to get help. She was like that, Catra knew.

“Oh?” O’Neill perked up. “Something came up?”

“Yes. Therapy.” Adora told him.

He seemed surprised, Catra noticed. Surprised and… that was a brief scowl. So, O’Neill didn’t like therapy? Or didn’t like them getting therapy? Either way, that was interesting.

“Therapy?” Daniel asked with a slightly puzzled expression.

“It’s an Earth treatment for trauma,” Catra told him, trying to look and sound as serious as possible.

“Oh, I know what…” Daniel trailed off, pouting, while Adora and Glimmer frowned at her, and O’Neill laughed.

Success! Catra grinned.

“Yes, we’re considering therapy,” Glimmer said with a fake smile. “Although it’s a quite controversial proposal.”

“Yeah.” O’Neill nodded in agreement. “I can imagine.”

“Oh?” Catra cocked her head at him. “Do you have experience with therapy?”

“Well, not personally,” O’Neill said. “But… the shrinks, I mean, the people who do the therapy, sometimes don’t really understand how things work, you know? They are a bit removed from, well, the reality of our lives out here. Or on the front.”

Catra glanced at Daniel, who was pressing his lips together and frowning at O’Neill. He obviously disagreed. But would he say so out loud? Probably, she decided. Daniel wasn’t one to hold back much. “I see,” she said. “So, you’ve never got therapy.”

“No.”

“And that wasn’t a good thing,” Daniel blurted out.

“Daniel,” O’Neill snapped with a glare.

“Jack!” Daniel shook his head as he met Jack’s eyes. “Therapy does help. Not every therapist is good, but not every officer is good either - and you don’t paint everyone with the same brush. That so many veterans don’t get therapy is a shame!”

The two stared at each other for a moment. Then O’Neill shrugged with a snort and slouched a bit in his seat. “There are too many stupid shrinks around who think they know best when they don’t know anything at all about the real world.”

“Many people would be happier with therapy. It’s not some hoax,” Daniel retorted.

“I can see how the topic is controversial,” Bow commented. He was grimacing a little.

And Adora looked torn, Catra noticed. Maybe she would reconsider this therapy thing - it wasn’t as if Catra was sold on it. But if it could help Adora with her issues, it was worth it.

“So, we already know that therapy isn’t some magic cure,” Glimmer spoke up, then frowned at O’Neill’s grin at her wording. “But what’s the worst that could happen if it doesn’t work? Can it hurt you?”

“You get sent to the loony bin,” O’Neill replied.

“Jack!” Daniel frowned.

“Loony bin?” Glimmer asked.

“A colloquial term for a psychiatric facility where people who are suffering from severe mental issues are treated, sometimes against their will,” Daniel explained.

“You mean psychologists can lock people up?” Adora blurted out. “On Earth?”

That was concerning, Catra had to agree. Well, they obviously wouldn’t be able to do it to a princess. Or to her - she’d shred anyone who tried.

“In very extreme cases, but it wouldn’t be psychologists, but psychiatrists,” Daniel said, glancing at O’Neill. “Those, ah, are specialists for mental illnesses. It’s not the same as treating trauma, even though lay people tend to mix them up.”

“You’re neither a psychologist nor a psychiatrist, Daniel.”

“But I know the difference, Jack.”

“Whatever,” Catra said. “So, seeing as anyone trying to lock up one of us would regret it, what’s the worst outcome that could realistically happen?”

“Manipulation,” O’Neill said after a moment. “The shrink will get to know you really well. Including some of your worst secrets. If he abuses your trust, he can manipulate you.”

Oh. Catra clenched her teeth. That sounded like…

“Shadow Weaver,” Adora muttered under her breath, copying Catra’s thought.

Glimmer’s as well, it seemed, judging by her expression. “Maybe we should reconsider this a bit more,” Glimmer said with a glance at Adora.

“Maybe.” Adora pressed her lips together as she nodded.

“Ah… it’s a matter of trust and trustworthiness.” Daniel smiled at them. “If you can’t trust your therapist, well… that’s obviously bad, but that’s the same with many things. Like your doctor. Or your, ah, portfolio manager.”

“What’s a portfolio manager?” Glimmer asked.

“People who manage your money,” Daniel explained. “If they betray your trust, they can steal a lot of your wealth.”

“You have people manage your wealth for you?” Bow asked.

“Only the rich, and only some of them,” O’Neill said. “Well, there’s also banking, which works the same.”

“In a very simplified way,” Daniel said. “But it was just an example that therapy isn’t a bad thing even if there might be untrustworthy therapists.”

“And we would have to judge that.” Glimmer still looked sceptical. With good reason, of course - in Catra’s opinion.

“Well, any psychologist working at Stargate Command was carefully vetted,” Daniel said.

“By your government.” Glimmer nodded.

Which didn’t mean that they could be trusted by Catra’s friends. They would have to find their own.

It looked like this would be even more difficult than it had seemed.

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“Yes, by our government, which is your trusted ally.” Jack O’Neill smiled widely and ignored Daniel’s frown. He was allowed a bit of sarcasm. And a good amount of caution was a very good thing when dealing with shrinks.

“Do you really think the US government will try to send spies to Etheria under the guise of psychologists?” Daniel asked. “That would be a very unfriendly act towards an ally.”

“Only if they get caught,” Jack said.

“But the consequences of such an operation being exposed… why would the government risk that?” Daniel shook his head.

“Oh, never underestimate how cocky spooks can be.” Jack grinned, showing his teeth. He knew that first-hand. “Or what they think they can get away with, as long as there’s plausible deniability.” Jack had no doubt that a number of spooks were acting as if the Cold War had never ended. Or had trouble adapting to a world where the United States wasn’t the superpower, or even a superpower, any more.

“But…” Daniel shook his head again - he hadn’t actually stopped, Jack realised. “They would risk the alliance! After all the trouble it took to get into it! Who would do that?”

“Kinsey?” Jack cocked his head. “Anyone from the NID?” Maybourne probably would love such an operation.

“Aren’t you supposed to portray your country as trustworthy and sympathetic?” Bow asked.

Jack shrugged. “The United States has its share of bad apples.” In often far too high positions, but still - it wasn’t as if the country was rotten to the core or something. “That doesn’t mean we’re the bad guys.”

“But there’s a risk of some of those ‘bad apples’ working against our best interest,” Glimmer said.

“Yep.”

“And if they get caught, they’ll claim to have operated without orders from your government,” Catra added.

“Yep. Though they would be telling the truth - the government wouldn’t give them such orders.”

“But they also wouldn’t order them not to do this.” Catra flashed her fangs. “In case they succeed.”

“Spooks have been known to interpret their orders creatively.” Jack shrugged again. “Some of them also have been operating quite independently.” And some had gone rogue.

“Well, so do we - SG-1, I mean. If we think our orders are stupid,” Daniel said.

Like when Apophis had attacked. “The difference is that we only acted when there was no other choice,” Jack said. And they had been right, of course. Unlike the NID.

“Your government seems to need better control over its spies,” Glimmer commented.

“Like we have control over Double Trouble?” Catra scoffed.

“They aren’t a member of the Alliance. They aren’t under our command at all,” Glimmer said.

“Well, of course, we’d say that!” Catra grinned.

“But we wouldn’t be lying about it!” Glimmer snapped. “And Double Trouble wouldn’t be acting for us but for themselves.”

Catra nodded, serious again.

Ah, yes. The Etherian superspy who could take the shape of anyone - and had the acting talent and experience to play the role convincingly. And who loved to cause drama and chaos for shit and giggles. Just knowing about Double Trouble had sent the various agencies in the United States into a frenzy. Hearing that the Etherians were also concerned about the spy didn’t help with that, of course. At least no one, except possibly Kinsey, was blaming Jack for that since he had never met the spy. At least as far as he knew - he could have met them without realising it. Easily.

And wasn’t that a comforting thought? Fortunately, Double Trouble was a unique case. At least as far as the Etherians knew. Of course, if Double Trouble were not such a showman, they

could have stayed in the shadows forever, so just because the Etherians were not aware of anyone else like Double Trouble didn't mean there was no such spy…

Ah! Jack reminded himself to stop that - he was starting to think like a spook again. And that wasn't a good thing.

And he didn't need a shrink to know that, either!

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Bright Moon, Etheria, January 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Therapy?" Sweet Bee sounded as if that was a dirty word, in Adora's opinion.

"Therapy?" Peekablue repeated although he sounded more as if he was honestly curious.

"Yes," Adora repeated. "It's a form of treatment for, ah, traumatic experiences that cause, uh, flashbacks that the people on Earth have developed. The treatment, not the flashbacks." She struggled not to bite her lower lip - she was stumbling over words she had heard so often in the last few days, she was probably dreaming of them! Then again, talking to Peekablue about it was different - he was so obviously suffering from it…

"They don't have magic; how could they develop this?" Sweet Bee asked, frowning.

"It's not a magical treatment," Adora explained. "It is based on psychological principles." She had prepared for that part, of course.

"What are psychological principles?" Sweet Bee still sounded doubtful.

And Catra had made fun of Adora for preparing to explain that as well! Adora nodded and launched into her next explanation. "It's

the science of studying the mind and behaviour. Well, the principles of such behaviour. Specifically, the principles of...”

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“...and that’s about it,” Adora finished her explanation, then looked at her guests. Although, technically, they were guests of Glimmer, and Adora was a guest in their room. Sort of. Protocol was kind of unclear about such visits since Adora was - technically - a guest as well in the palace, but it was also her home. And she wasn’t a subordinate of Glimmer, which further complicated matters. It would only be more complicated if this were the Princess Prom.

Sweet Bee still was frowning. Even more so than before, actually, Adora realised with a sinking feeling in her stomach. Had she botched the explanation? Maybe she shouldn’t have come alone, but Sweet Bee didn’t get along with most of Adora’s friends, especially Catra and Glimmer. Though she also didn’t get along with Adora…

“So… You want us to talk to Earth healers about our problems so they can analyse us.” Sweet Beet stared at her.

That was… technically correct, but not in that sense. “I think this could help you get better about, you know,” Adora replied, looking at Peekablue. This was about him, after all - Sweet Bee wasn’t traumatised by war.

“I see.” Peekablue smiled faintly. “But I also see the risks of being taken advantage of.”

“And of feeling obligated,” Sweet Bee added.

“What? No!” Adora shook her head. “This isn’t a trade; this is an honest offer to help you. No strings attached!” What did they think she was doing?

“So you say. And you might mean it. But you’d have to be a very selfish person not to feel an obligation to return such a favour,”

Sweet Bee said. “Glimmer has been quite clear about the fact that she expects us to be grateful for the protection the Alliance provides. Whether or not we want it.”

Well, that was… not entirely wrong. Glimmer had been vocal about people profiting from the sacrifices of the Alliance. But it wasn’t right either. Adora shook her head. “Glimmer was talking about using the Stargate without contributing to its security.” And putting Etheria at risk, which was kind of a negative contribution to the gate security, as Bow had described it.

Sweet Bee rolled her eyes, but Peekablue slowly nodded. “But you don’t want to share responsibility over the Stargate’s operation - you want to control it.”

“We kind of have to,” Adora said, trying not to wince. “It’s crucial for the war effort.”

Sweet Bee scoffed at that. “The usual excuse!”

“It’s not an excuse. We need the Stargate to wage the war - the distances are too big for alternatives,” Adora told her. Sure, there was the communication network Entrapta and Sam’s spy bots were putting up, but that could only handle communication - they certainly couldn’t move princesses and other people through it.

“Earth nominally has the whole planet contributing to secure the Stargate, but the Alliance effectively controls it as well there,” Peekablue pointed out.

“Which is a problem. You want us to contribute to the defence of Etheria, but we wouldn’t have any say about how it’s being handled.” Sweet Bee shook her head. “The Alliance is just too big for Etheria.”

“Do you want us to break up? In the middle of the war?” Adora shook her head. That would be crazy! And they couldn’t expect the princesses to stop being friends! That wasn’t how it worked!

“No,” Peekablue spoke again, cutting off what Sweet Bee had been about to say. “But we expect you to acknowledge that you are so powerful, what the smaller kingdoms could contribute to the war wouldn’t matter at all.” He leaned forward in his seat, staring - for the first time, ever - directly at Adora and meeting her eyes. “War has traditionally been the business of princesses. Of course, soldiers served and fought in various roles, but a war was generally decided by princesses matching up against each other. The Horde broke that tradition.”

Well, Hordak wasn’t a princess. Though, technically, he was powerful enough to be treated as one, he hadn’t been raised on Etheria. Of course, he’d fight a war differently.

“Yes. The Horde fought differently. And now they’re part of the Alliance,” Sweet Bee said.

“Well… yes?” Adora didn’t shrug; that would have been rude. It was obvious that the Alliance would have taken in former Horde soldiers; that was the right thing to do. And the smart thing to do, as Catra would put it.

“But you - at least most of the Alliance - seem to expect that everyone else continues the same as before,” Peekablue said. “Even though things have changed drastically. Earth kingdoms have no princesses - but many times the population of Etheria. And you have Horde Prime’s fleet of ships and the Horde army of bots. What do you need anyone else for? Why do you want more people to be exposed to the horrors of war? You already have enough soldiers.”

That was… it wasn’t like that! “We don’t expect everyone to fight,” Adora protested. “You can help in other ways as well if you want to.”

“You’d have our artisans craft a skiff while the factories of the Alliance and Earth spit out shuttles by the dozens?” Peekablue shook his head. “What for? A skiff more or less wouldn’t really change anything for a war on this scale.”

“But a skiff more or less would change a lot for a family on Etheria. Or a village. Not every kingdom is large or rich,” Sweet Bee added.

“Trading with Earth will change a lot as well,” Adora pointed out. “And you are planning that.”

“Yes. We have to,” Sweet Bee told her. “But that trade will be more equal, and more profitable, than just working for the Alliance. We won’t have to turn into the Horde for this. We won’t have to change as much. We will be able to control it.”

“We hope so, at least,” Peekablue said. “We might be wrong, but we have to try anyway. We owe it to our people.”

Sweet Bee nodded firmly.

Adora winced. She should have taken someone else with her. She hadn’t come for this. “I see,” she said, smiling wryly when Peekablue raised his eyebrows. “But I didn’t come here to discuss politics. I wanted to talk to you about therapy, nothing more. It might help you with your… issue.” He was suffering, and he shouldn’t be. No one should.

Sweet Bee and Peekablue exchanged a glance. “We’ll consider it,” he said.

Adora wasn’t a politician, but she knew that was a polite way to say no. Catra would tell her she told her so. But Adora had had to try, at least.

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The Therapy Question Part 2

Bright Moon, Etheria, January 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"I already told you the last time you mentioned this: I do not need therapy."

"But you do! Data doesn't lie!"

Samantha Carter tried not to wince at the exchange between Entrapta and Hordak. She hadn't asked, but it seemed clear that this disagreement had been going on for a while. Probably since her last visit, during which the same argument had ended inconclusively. And she was pretty certain that the two wouldn't be able to find a solution. It was obvious that Entrapta wanted the best for her lover, but Sam knew that her friend didn't fully understand, well, people. She meant well, and she was friendly, but dealing with such a situation was beyond her.

And Hordak was… about the same. He was far less friendly, of course, than Entrapta - gruff, most of the time - but he was as socially awkward, though it expressed itself a bit differently. And he had been raised, and socialised, by Horde Prime, who, by all accounts, made Ra look pleasant and humble in comparison.

Which meant it would need outside intervention to solve this before the two hurt each other. At least emotionally. And absent their other friends, it seemed as if Sam would have to step up and intervene.

Great.

She took a deep breath, then stepped forward, not quite between Entrapta and Hordak - a table with the latest prototype of an improved bot blaster cannon prevented that - but close enough. "Please, stop for a moment."

Both turned to look at her, and Sam had to turn her head back and forth to watch both of them. That was… not optimal.

“Sam! The data doesn’t lie!” Entrapta wasn’t wringing her hands, but her hair tendrils were moving a bit erratically - she was upset.

Before Sam could reply, Hordak scoffed, crossing his arms over his chest. “The data is not applicable. It’s about humans. I am not human.”

“But the principles are the same!”

“You don’t know that.”

“But the symptoms match!” Entrapta retorted.

“The symptoms can vary wildly, so that is no proof. You display similar symptoms at times.” Hordak shook his head.

Entrapta looked taken aback. “Well, yes. I might need therapy as well. But the data is clear that I cannot objectively judge my own mental state, and we don’t have anyone yet who’s qualified to do so.”

“Then you can’t judge my mental state either.” Hordak sounded almost smug.

“But I can compare the data! And the data is solid enough to deduce that you should see a therapist. If my conclusion is wrong, the therapist will tell you.” Entrapta nodded firmly. “That’s the obvious solution: See an experienced professional.”

They were ignoring Sam again. That was… quite a new experience.

“Professional means they do it for a living. That means they have ample incentive to claim a need for their services, so their judgment would be biased,” Hordak retorted. “And the incentive for a spy working as a therapist to make a false claim is even bigger since that would allow them to gather information about us.”

That was not wrong, technically, but quite biased itself. On the other hand, Sam was very much aware of and shared the Colonel's view that the NID and other agencies wouldn't hesitate to use such underhanded means to gain more information and potential leverage on the Etherians.

"Then we just need to find a trustworthy therapist!" Entrapta nodded. "Please! It's going to help!"

"Glimmer and the others haven't found a trustworthy therapist yet, and the odds of them managing that feat are not good." Hordak snorted.

"I have confidence in them," Entrapta replied. "They'll succeed."

"How could they? This is completely out of their experience. How could they find a trustworthy therapist amongst the corrupt or compromised?" Hordak shook his head again. "And even them, it wouldn't work since I am not a human. A therapist with experience with humans couldn't adequately judge my mental state."

Sam had to press her lips together to avoid blurting out that you didn't need a degree to determine that Hordak wasn't in a good mental state and needed help. But he was correct in that he wasn't human. His mind might not work the same way as a human's did. On the other hand, he acted all too human, in Sam's experience. Close enough, in any case, to not appear truly alien. "I think the basic principles are the same," she said.

Entrapta beamed at her, and Hordak scowled.

"But I am not a psychologist. Although I don't think talking to one would hurt," Sam went on.

"Unless they are a spy," Hordak spat. "The risks are too great for the small probability of success."

"That's not how science works!" Entrapta protested. "If an experiment is too dangerous, you take steps to make it safer!"

“This isn’t an experiment!” Hordak retorted.

But Entrapta smiled. “It’s a way to gather data - close enough. So, how can we reduce the risk of this harming us?” She cocked her head and looked at Sam.

“Ah…” Sam was at a loss.

“How did you pick your therapist?” Entrapta asked.

Sam didn’t. She went to her mandatory counselling sessions when ordered to, and that was it. Officers who thought they needed additional therapy and told the Air Force so would have poor prospects for promotions. Or for being trusted with top-secret projects. But her friend needed an answer. “Well… people tend to look for references when picking a therapist.”

“References?” Entrapta frowned.

“They ask their friends if they know a trustworthy therapist,” Sam explained. At least, that was what Sam had heard - it wasn’t as if she knew anyone who would actually talk about needing therapy in her social circle. Except, now, for the Etherians. And wasn’t that ironic?

“Good. So, who would you recommend?” Entrapta beamed at her, obviously expecting an answer.

Sam winced. “Well, I actually don’t know a therapist…” Entrapta’s face fell, and Hordak started to smile. Or what passed for a smile for him. Sam quickly added: “But I can ask around.”

“Great!”

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, January 26th, 1999

“So, as you can see, the electronic reconnaissance has resulted in inconclusive data. Although we managed to get closer to the unidentified fleet with a spy bot without getting detected, we could not determine their identity. Well, we already knew what ships were there and how many, but their transponders are not set to any signal in use by a System Lord - or any that had been used by one in the past. Or by a past System Lord. Which kinda is the same, but it’s not quite the same. Anyway! Also, optical sensors were not powerful enough to make out any ship names on the hulls from that distance. I wanted to fly closer, but Sam said that wouldn’t be safe and the risk of detection was too high. Even though we would then get better data on the fleet’s sensor net capability.”

Catra suppressed a sigh at Entrapta and slid a bit forward in her seat. Her friend was pouting - she obviously disagreed with the risk assessment. But knowing how good the enemy’s sensors were wouldn’t be useful if the enemy would, in turn, be rendered aware of the spy bot network.

One of the Earth officers - the British admiral - nodded. “Yes. We must keep the enemy from becoming aware of our capabilities for as long as possible. As long as they think Earth stands alone, they’ll underestimate us.”

“And might attribute our attacks to rival System Lords,” General Naird added. Catra still didn’t know why the USA had sent that guy to this meeting. Jack claimed he was one of their best ‘Space Force officers’, but that was probably just Air Force propaganda. Can’t show weakness against the Navy or something - sometimes, it felt as if the Air Force considered the other parts of the American forces their most dangerous enemy…

“Anyway, since we apparently shouldn’t use the spy bots to spy on the fleet - and they aren’t happy about that, let me tell you! Well, they wouldn’t be happy about it if they had their control matrixes enhanced to include emotions, which they haven’t since that would be bad, but the principle stands - and the Tok’ra haven’t found out anything either…”

“So far,” Anise cut in with a frown. “We’re working on it.”

Why the Tok’ra had sent Anise… well, they probably counted on getting an in with Sam and Entrapta through Anise and getting more technology through shared research. That’s what Catra would have done in their place.

“Yes, of course - you don’t stop researching. But! Since we can’t be sure this will produce more data, we have to focus on an alternative.” Entrapta nodded at Sam and Anise.

On the large screen behind her, an unfamiliar shuttle appeared. “We can use this to test our latest stealth shuttle!” Entrapta beamed at everyone in the room. “Since it’s a new design, not a First One shuttle or adapted Horde model, no one will know it’s us even if they detect us - which they shouldn’t according to our current data. Unless we leave the shuttle and meet them, I guess. Or we get boarded, but we could be wearing masks in that case.”

Or ensure that no one who boarded them made it out alive, Catra mentally added.

“Since it’s a new class, we will have to train the crews, I assume,” the British Admiral said. “That might delay the mission. Possibly long enough for the fleet to become active.”

“Oh, that’s always a risk,” Entrapta told him. “They could go active right now, though we would hear about it almost instantly. But without more data, we can’t make any educated guess as to their plans. But!” She smiled widely. “Since it’s our design, we can crew it, so you don’t have to wait for someone else to learn how it works. Which is a good thing since we might want to make some changes to how it works based on how this mission goes, and if we’re in the shuttle, we can do it in the middle of the mission!”

Adora cleared her throat. “The crew will be composed of selected individuals from both Earth and Etheria with experience in such missions and the skills to handle a variety of unexpected situations, including diplomacy.”

Catra caught Naird muttering something about ‘SG-1 again’, but she ignored that. It wasn’t as if they had better alternatives, and she would rather work with people she could trust - both to be able to handle this kind of mission and to not betray them - than someone new and unknown.

“That’s a quite diverse set of skills you’ll need for this. Do you have individuals in mind already?” the German General asked.

“Yes. Myself and my friends, and SG-1,” Adora told him. “But if you wish to add someone else to the mission, we should have room for them.”

Catra leaned back and stretched as the first suggestion to leave the mission to expendable crew members instead of the Alliance leadership was voiced. They really should know better by now. Princesses led from the front.

And it wasn’t as if there was a better team to handle this than the BFS and SG-1. Especially if something unexpected happened.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 26th, 1999

“So, we’re volunteering to go on a recon mission?” Jack O’Neill asked, leaning forward in his seat in the briefing room and putting his elbows on the table.

“Well… only if you want to, of course,” Adora told him. “Otherwise, it wouldn’t be volunteering. And we only want volunteers.”

“We’re not in the Horde; volunteering means volunteering here,” Catra said, flashing her fangs.

Jack was tempted to correct her, but Entrapta spoke up before he could think o the perfect way to explain ‘voluntold’: “But we could really use Sam! We’re going to use our new shuttle design!”

Jack turned to look at Carter. “A new shuttle design? And you didn’t ask me for my input? I’m hurt, Captain!”

Her eyes widened for a moment before they narrowed. “I wasn’t aware you were a spacecraft designer or an engineer, sir.”

“I’m a pilot,” he told her. “One of the guys who’s going to fly those things. You know, those who will suffer from ergonomic mistakes all their lives.”

Once more, Entrapta butted in: “That’s great! You can test the layout of the bridge on this mission, then, and suggest any changes afterwards! You’ll be our test pilot! Well, our first human test pilot!”

“Is it a good idea to use a dangerous recon mission to test a new design?” Daniel asked with a frown.

Jack raised his eyebrows at Carter. Daniel was always a bit of a spoilsport, but the question had merit. It was ‘train as you fight’, not ‘test while you fight’. Although he knew Carter - she wouldn’t have them risk their lives in untested experimental designs. Not unless the situation was truly desperate. Which this wasn’t.

“The design already underwent extensive testing, sir,” she replied. “And it passed every benchmark.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded three times, her hair bopping. “It’s ready for field testing.”

“That’s still testing, isn’t it?” Daniel said.

“Technically, yes,” Carter told him. “But it’s safe.”

“Yes! We already did the destructive testing! And the stealth system doesn’t overheat any more! Not that that was too much of a problem unless you were in the engine room without a space suit. Or left the door open.”

That wasn't nearly as reassuring as it should be. But Jack trusted Carter to keep Entrapta's enthusiasm for bypassing security measures in check.

"Well, are you in?" Catra asked. "Your general didn't seem happy about the plan."

Jack had to briefly remind himself that she didn't mean Hammond. That would be a change once they left Stargate Command for good. "Naird?" he asked.

"Yeah." Catra shrugged. "What's his problem? Jealous he can't go on the mission?"

"He could have asked if he wanted to come along! We even asked for such suggestions!" Adora added.

"General-rank officers rarely go on recon missions," Jack told her. Though he wouldn't put it past Naird to try and finagle such a mission - the guy was still trying to get approval for a 'familiarisation flight' to the moon. But he probably had used up too many favours to get a seat at the Alliance table. Of course, that was a good thing since he was Air Force - the Navy was still trying to gain control over the new Space Force in the making. If they got their way… Jack almost shuddered at the thought of wearing a Navy uniform. "No, we're in. Right, folks?" Couldn't let Carter have all the fun. And Jack was looking forward to getting some stick time in a shuttle on an actual mission - just the bragging rights if he met another Blackbird crew boasting about the speed of their plane would be worth it.

"Yes, sir."

"Of course, Jack."

"Indeed."

"Great!" Entrapta beamed. "This will be such a nice trip!"

“And we’ll be taking a task force there with enough firepower to take the enemy fleet out,” Glimmer said.

Ah, that was the style of recon Jack could get behind. Find the enemy and destroy them at the same time.

“If it is an enemy fleet,” Bow cautioned. “We don’t know that.”

“It’s made up of Ha’taks, Al’kesh and Tel’taks,” Catra said. “All Goa’uld ship classes. Who else do you think is flying those? We already know they don’t belong to the Tok’ra.”

“Well, it could be another splinter faction and potential ally,” Daniel pointed out. “All I am saying is that we shouldn’t assume they’re hostile.”

Jack shook his head. When it came to the snakes, assuming the worst was best.

“We’ll see,” Glimmer said. “That’s why we’re doing a recon mission. If they aren’t part of a System Lord’s fleet, we’ll find out.”

“They are taking quite the precautions to hide their allegiance, according to what we already know,” Teal’c spoke up. “If they are observing strict security protocols, finding out who they answer to might be a challenge even for someone with your skill at penetrating Goa’uld computer security, Captain Carter.”

“If we can’t hack their systems, we’ll have to sneak into their ships and take a look ourselves,” Glimmer said with a grin. “Shouldn’t be too hard even if I can’t teleport us into a Ha’tak.”

Now that was a mission Jack could get behind!

“We could use a ring transporter, but that’s kinda tricky. Even without active counter-measures - and the Goa’uld know how to block transporters - interference can build up. We were working on linking the transporter to our improved scanner, but the signal lag is still a factor. So, we’ll probably have to sneak on board using

spacesuits," Entrapta said. "Good thing we have spacesuits for all of us!"

Jack grinned.

This should be fun.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, January 26th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...so we've been working on stealth shuttles for some time, between our other projects. First we were mostly focused on trying to duplicate the ones we have. Which was harder than expected, even though it shouldn't have been. It's that Horde standards don't mesh well with First One technology, probably because Horde Prime didn't want compatible technology or something, which is why the Horde factories didn't really work well for producing the prototypes. So we switched to modifying Horde designs to create a new stealth shuttle. Well, we ended up using a mostly new design using Horde technology and matched it with better stealth generators based on First Ones technology once we had the interfaces adapted, for which Sam's experience with linking First Ones and Goa'uld tech was really helpful. And it also means that the Third Fleet's supply train can assemble the prototypes, and we didn't need to build or repurpose an existing shuttle factory for it. That would have been bad, Sam said, since everyone wants more shuttles - everyone on Earth, at least - and this would have cut into shuttle production. I don't get that, actually, since the new design is obviously superior, so we will have to switch over anyway." Entrapta shrugged without stopping her explanation as she led Adora and the others through Priest's flagship towards the hangar. "Anyway! Sam also said switching a factory would have caused a delay, and they would have wanted a 'proven design', so maybe we can switch all factories over after his test mission?"

Adora blinked, trying to sort out what Entrapta had just said. If her friend got really enthusiastic, she tended to talk very fast and very much, and it was a bit of a challenge to keep up. Even when she wasn't talking about technology that Adora didn't quite understand.

At least Glimmer looked like she had the same trouble, though Bow was nodding.

"Good luck trying to get the Tau'ri to make any changes to their plans," Catra said with a snort. "I bet they'll need at least three months just debating it before deciding if they do it."

Adora frowned a little. That was… well, not completely wrong, but not fair. Earth leaders could make quick decisions. Sometimes.

Glimmer giggled, though, and Bow smiled. "Well, they just built the new factories, so changing everything might not sit well with them. They'd have to retrain the workers as well," he said.

"But that's the fun part! Learning new technology!" Entrapta protested.

"It's also a matter of costs," Adora pointed out. "And most of the missions they want the shuttles for don't require stealth capabilities. They just want fast and tough transports."

"And I bet that they don't want all of their shuttles to be stealth shuttles," Catra added. "They don't want everyone else being able to sneak around."

Adora nodded. Earth people were already concerned with advanced technology being stolen and used by others. Of course, with Entrapta and Sam's scanner, they could detect any piece using Naquadah on Earth, so that wasn't such a huge deal, in her opinion.

"It still makes no sense!" Entrapta insisted. "And we are still starting out with building shuttles - it's easier to switch now instead of later."

Catra shrugged. “It would be nice to have just one model of shuttles to maintain in the field, but we can’t count on the Goa’uld remaining static. Sooner or later, they’ll adapt, so we need to stay a step ahead of them.”

That was also true. Adora nodded as they reached the hangar.

“And here it is! The new stealth shuttle prototype, the Esmeralda Mark V!” Entrapta spread her arms and hair, beaming at the shuttle in the middle of the hangar.

“Esmeralda?” Glimmer asked.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded several times. “It’s a nice name. Emily approves.”

Catra snorted, and Adora frowned at her lover. Esmeralda was a perfectly good name, as far as she knew at least.

“So, can we take it out for a spin?” Catra asked.

“Once Sam and the others arrive,” Adora told her. Their friends from SG-1 had been held up by a meeting with the Stargate Command Council. Or was that the Stargate Command Command Council? In any case, it seemed SG-1 required formal orders to join them on the mission, and while that was merely a formality, the Russian general was being difficult or something. “We don’t want to go over the briefing twice.”

“I can sleep through the second briefing.” Catra grinned.

“I don’t mind explaining twice!” Entrapta smiled widely. “Sam said, most stuff you have to explain repeatedly anyway, so people get it.”

Catra snickered at that, of course.

“Anyway, if you look at it, it’s basically a modified Horde space transport. We added the stealth systems, so it got about half the cargo capacity, and we improved the sensors - although in stealth

mode, you are limited to passive sensors and magic, since active sensors would give you away, and that would defeat the stealth mode. But it got the latest magitech sensor we could build. For now, at least."

"What about armament?" Glimmer asked. "Those look like turrets." She pointed at the shuttle.

"Yes! Two turrets with two blaster cannons each, one on every side. They're remote-controlled and mounted on the armour, so they're kind of vulnerable, but we would have had to compromise armour integrity if we had mounted them inside the armour, and compared to the shield generator, the armour is not that effective anyway."

That sounds a little… confusing, Adora thought.

"I wanted missile launchers as well, but we didn't have the space for that. Maybe with the next upgrade, we can add them to the underside. Anyway, let me show you the interior! Esmeralda, open up!"

A ramp started to descend in the back of the shuttle, and Adora smiled. Entrapta was always so enthusiastic about her projects. It was great to see someone so passionate.

"Ah! Your Divine Highness, praised be Your name as we bask in Your holy presence as you inspect Your next blessed vessel!"

Adora's smile froze as she noticed Priest standing on the ramp. She should have realised that he wouldn't miss the chance to meet her. That was a kind of passion she really didn't need.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, January 26th, 1999

"If this had been an emergency, we'd all be dead by now," the Colonel commented as they walked towards the base's landing

pad. Or the base's shuttle port, as most had started to call it. "From old age, probably."

"But it wasn't an emergency, Jack," Daniel spoke up. "Besides, if it had been an emergency, and we'd die from old age, then wouldn't that mean it wasn't an emergency in the first place?" he added with a frown. Then his eyes widened. "Uh, I mean… not like…" He trailed off with a sheepish expression. "Sorry."

Samantha Carter suppressed a sigh. In a way, Daniel was a bit like Adora, blaming himself for things that weren't his fault.

The Colonel snorted. "I brought it up. Don't feel bad about it. It was just a joke."

Sam managed not to shudder at the memory of that mission to Argos. When the Colonel had started to age rapidly, growing older, weaker, practically by the day, and she had frantically tried to stop the process, to save him, before he died of old age in front of her… She shook her head. He hadn't died. His age had been restored. And since She-Ra had healed him, he was even healthier than before. Probably the healthiest he had ever been, given his past and lifestyle. And it showed…

"So, Carter," the Colonel interrupted her inappropriate thoughts. "Are there any other secret projects of yours that you'd like to share with the class?"

Sam cocked her head at him. "Sir?"

He snorted again, obviously not fooled. Not that she had expected that, anyway - but some forms, even informal ones, had to be observed. "Your stealth shuttle project was a surprise to everyone. Sneaky of you, by the way. How many other such projects do you have going between you and our mad scientist princess?"

"We're still trying to decode the alien data cube we found on the way back to Earth from Etheria," she told him.

"Still? I'd have expected you to crack it over lunch."

Another joke, but Sam knew the Colonel trusted her competence, so even a mild joke stung a little. "It's a very complex challenge, sir. We have to deal with a completely different architecture and likely very alien language influences. And we have had to prioritise other projects for the war. Such as the self-replicating spy drone network." And a few more projects Entrapta and Sam had come up with but not seriously pursued. And there was more found technology to analyse. And interface issues for Earth weapon developers to deal with. And paperwork.

"Not even a hint of future surprises?" The Colonel grinned.

"We've got a wide range of potential projects. It's impossible to predict which will reach a breakthrough and which won't." That was how research worked. Something those in charge of her budget never seemed to understand. But working with Entrapta had been a huge help with that problem - as a sovereign ruler and key member of the Princess Alliance, Sam's friend didn't have to deal with bean counters and penny pinchers. Not to the extent a captain in the Air Force had to, at least. Fortunately, officially entering the war had led to massively expanded research budgets for Sam as well.

They reached the shuttle waiting for them - the same that had carried Entrapta into orbit while SG-1 had had to deal with the Command Council. Or, to be more precise, with Sidorov and Li stalling them for reasons only Russia and China knew. Probably related to the recent diplomatic visit by Sweet Bee and Peekablue.

But they had received official orders to join the Alliance task force for the recon mission, and that was all that mattered now, Sam reminded herself as they boarded the shuttle.

"Welcome aboard!" the clone pilot greeted them, smiling as widely as a flight attendant greeting First Class passengers. Maybe even more so.

"That feels creepy, all that cheerfulness," the Colonel grumbled as they took their seats and the pilot had retired to the bridge.

"You'd say the same about a bot pilot," Daniel told him. "Why don't you commandeer the shuttle and fly it yourself?"

"I already got my flight hours for this period," he replied. "I wouldn't want to abuse my rank."

Daniel gave him a flat look, and Sam narrowed her eyes a bit herself. Even Teal'c raised his eyebrow a smidge.

"Well, I'm going to test fly the stealth shuttle soon," the Colonel admitted with a grin.

"It handles quite similarly," Sam told him, smiling slightly when he frowned a bit at the reminder that she had flown the new shuttle before.

Then the shuttle took off, and they quickly left Colorado and then the atmosphere behind them. It still felt a bit weird to Sam how quickly space travel had become normal. Reaching orbit felt almost banal. Like commuting to work.

She wondered how the NASA team preparing for Mars felt about that. Were they excited - or did they resent the fact that, but for Alliance orders restricting shuttle flight paths to near Earth, anyone in a shuttle could have reached the planet already? But the mission had better start soon; there was talk about using Mars as a training location for Alliance marines, to prepare them for landing operations on hostile planets. And that would rob the NASA mission of even more of its fading mystique. Of course, planting a few bases on Mars wouldn't change the fact that it was barely explored and could hold untold mysteries, but it wouldn't feel nearly the same.

But that wasn't Sam's problem, she reminded herself. She had to focus on the new stealth shuttle and the upcoming recon mission.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, January 26th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and that's the passive stealth system, minimising our sensor signature. It reduces the range at which we can be detected by Goa'uld sensors by a factor of two compared to the standard Alliance shuttle."

While Sam explained, Catra cocked her head and looked through the cockpit - or bridge - windows. The frigate they had launched from was just a speck in the black now. Which meant Priest was just about far enough away for Adora to relax again. Which was a good thing, even though her reaction to his praise had been cute.

"It's actually kind of a misnomer," Entrapta added. "It's not as much a system, but design choices that make detecting the shuttle harder - provided that people are using sensors we know of. The stealth system, on the other hand, is an active system masking our presence - including a camouflage field warping the light around us. From the outside, we're almost invisible. But! We also have a camouflage system that can be set to make us look like we're transparent - because warping the light around us might not always work best, say if we're on a planet's surface and the warping effect could be noticed. It shouldn't, but it could. But the camouflage - which can also change the paint coat of the shuttle to any you want, in case the normal one gets boring - is optimised for that kind of hiding."

That sounded… very impressive.

"Like a ring of invisibility. Now you're just missing the SEP field generator," O'Neill said with a grin.

"What's a SEP field?" Entrapta asked. "Did we forget something? I thought we covered all sensors that we knew of."

"It's from a novel series," Sam said, frowning at O'Neill. "It's fictional - not real."

"Oh. What does it do?" Entrapta cocked her head.

"It makes people think that whatever it surrounds is 'somebody else's problem'," Daniel explained. "And asking about it tells us

that Jack has read the novels," he added with a grin.

"If you're stuck at a base far from civilisation, you'll read anything in the library," O'Neill said with a frown.

"Well… that might be possible with a spell, I think," Entrapta said. "And it would probably help if you want to shoot at something without being detected. That's kind of a problem we haven't been able to solve yet."

"It's theoretically possible, yes," Glimmer agreed. "But that kind of magic would require tampering with the mind of everyone affected - and that's… a very questionable kind of magic."

Catra nodded - that kind of magic, in the wrong hands, like Shadow Weaver's… She felt the fur on the back of her neck bristle at the thought. She smirked at Adora to distract herself. "And I guess it wouldn't work on the kind of people who think every problem is their responsibility, huh?"

Adora pouted at her. "We can't exactly test that."

"And we would have to create a magitech device to replicate the effect. That could be tricky," Entrapta added. "Although… if we could reverse-engineer the technology that we encountered on Beast Island, the device that made people want to stop doing anything…"

That had happened when Catra had sent Entrapta to Beast Island for not wanting to risk destroying the world to win the war… She clenched her teeth at the reminder of her folly. She had almost destroyed everyone. And it had cost Glimmer her mother. It was…

"I don't think we should build or use that," Glimmer said, shivering. "And it might not work on Goa'uld - or Jaffa. Dad wasn't affected, and he was there for years."

"Yeah, best not build a brainwashing machine like that. Dictators would love it to turn their people into mindless sheep," O'Neill said.

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. “We don’t want to follow Horde Prime’s example.”

No, we really don’t want, Catra thought. Mind control was… She clenched her teeth. Anyone who had suffered from Horde Prime’s chips would agree with that.

“The ends don’t justify the means,” Bow added.

Hordak nodded without saying anything. But he was looking at Entrapta, Catra noticed.

And her friend looked a bit sheepish. “Anyway, we also thought about a system that could actually alter the hull, but that would require a lot more research and testing. And we didn’t have the time for that. But imagine a shuttle that could look like another type of ship! Well, with roughly the same mass, but still! That would be great, right?”

Perfect for infiltration missions. Like.. a ship version of Double Trouble. Catra gritted her teeth at the unwanted stray thought. This was supposed to be a test flight in a new shuttle, not a trip down memory lane, as the Tau’ri liked to say. Not to memories she really didn’t want to revisit. “So, can we see how that works?” she said.

“Oh, sure! Well, kinda - the light-warping system makes it so you can’t actually see out any more, so you kind of see and don’t. But other sensors still work, so we installed screens for that,” Entrapta explained with a wide smile. But if you’re outside the field, you can see it - well, you can’t see it any more, which tells you it’s working. So, you want to go outside?”

“Maybe later,” Catra told her, taking a step closer to Adora.

“Alright, so… here we go!”

Entrapta flipped a switch with her hair, and the stars and the curve of Earth outside the shuttle’s windows vanished.

*****

Jack O'Neill grinned as he took the shuttle through another loop. Sneaky Carter hadn't mentioned that she and Entrapta also had improved the performance of the shuttle's engines. Or maybe she had, and he had missed it, but he usually paid attention to critical information such as that.

Unfortunately, they were doing the test flight in space, not in the atmosphere, and so Jack couldn't do some nap-of-the-earth flying. The moon was a bit too far away to coincidentally approach. There was the frigate, but… playing chicken with large movable objects you launched from was for Navy pukes.

He blinked. Oh, for… He had launched in a small spaceship from a large spaceship. Like a Navy puke. Worse, he had thought of this as a carrier operation, not an Air Force mission. Damn. No one could ever know!

"Is something wrong, Jack?" Entrapta, who was sitting in the co-pilot seat while the rest of SG-1 and the Etherians were in the back checking the stealth system, asked. "You're frowning, which usually means something is wrong. Is there an issue with the shuttle? The readings are all within expected parameters, but…"

"No, no, everything is fine. Better than fine, actually," Jack was quick to assure her. "I just remembered something unpleasant."

"Oh? Something unpleasant?"

"And private," he told her.

"Oh. OK, private. That means no prying. Unless it's for your own good." Entrapta sounded as if she was repeating a lesson. She probably was, Jack realised.

He really didn't want to touch that, so he changed the subject. "So, how do we test the weapons? Do you have target drones out there?"

“Oh, no - this was supposed to be a test for the stealth and flight systems. We’ve tested the weapons in the lab - well, they’re standard Horde blaster cannons, and the power supply was tested and works, and the remote controls are from proven designs - I wanted to improve them, maybe turn them into bots, or make them detachable so they could act as escorts or attack craft, but Sam said we should focus on the stealth system… anyway, they should work.”

“Never assume a weapon works without live firing,” he told her. “Preferably until it breaks, so you know its limits.”

“That’s what Hordak says as well. Catra says it’s fun, too.”

Jack managed not to scowl. He didn’t want to be compared to Mr Former Warlord. Even if the guy was correct. “So, how about we fire on the frigate? The shields can take it, right?” he joked.

“Oh, yes. That’s probably a faster solution than building a few target bots from spare parts,” Entrapta replied. “But we probably should tell them first.”

“Yes.” Entrapta often had trouble getting jokes, Jack reminded himself. “And we should inform Earth so they don’t think there’s a coup going on or something.” Or an attack by enemy stealth ships - the stealth system hid them from Earth sensors as well, after all, as they had already found out.

“Right! That would be bad, I think.”

“Yes.” Jack could imagine what might happen if a bunch of fanatics thought their goddess wanted a specific ship destroyed. And the panic it would cause on Earth.

So, a few calls and some narrowed eyes from Carter later, they were happily flying loops around Priest’s flagship and shooting at its shields. Which was fun but also a bit disappointing - obviously, the fact that the shields regenerated faster than the shuttle could damage them meant that a stealth shuttle - or a space fighter, like he had heard being discussed - wasn’t really going to be effective

against a larger ship. Unless you sent tons of them against it. "We need missiles," he said. "Big honking missiles." Torpedoes, even if that sounded like a Navy thing as well.

"We're working on that. Unfortunately, the stealth system is too big for the missiles we have," Entrapta told him. "And reducing its size has hit a few snags since some components don't work if we make them smaller - we haven't found a way to miniaturise them yet."

Jack hadn't thought about stealth missiles. Just normal missiles would be useful - though they would allow the enemy to track the launch location. But stealth missiles… "What about making the missiles bigger?"

"Hm. They would have to be half the size of a shuttle for the stealth system to work. Maybe a little smaller. And that means we couldn't launch them from a shuttle. I think."

That sounded more like a kamikaze shuttle than a missile. An unmanned kamikaze shuttle. Maybe a Kamikaze bot? "Well, if it can fly like a shuttle, we can launch it from a frigate," Jack suggested.

"Well, yes. But it would also have to be able to get through a shield. That's easier the smaller something is, once the shield starts wavering. A shuttle-sized missile…" Entrapta made some humming noise, and Jack could hear her hair typing. "The shield would have to be almost completely gone to get through it. On a spaceship, at least."

And at that point, you didn't really need stealth any more. A pity.

Well - the shuttle was meant to deliver soldiers to their targets, not to shoot down enemy ships. But Jack would have liked to have the option.

On the other hand, in a pinch, Carter could probably whip up something on the fly if they needed it. And Jack had no doubt that space fighter/bombers would be a thing soon enough.

But, most importantly, they were now ready for the recon mission. Jack couldn’t wait to use the shuttle for real.

*****

Scouting Part 1

Earth Orbit, Solar System, January 27th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Oh, Your Divine Highness, blessed are we by Your shining presence. We strike out in Your name to bring the light of You to those struggling under the cruel yoke of evil! Just as You have vanquished the Great Deceiver, cursed be his name for all eternity, so shall we vanquish those who oppress others. In Your holy name, we shall fight all comers, ready to lay down our lives for Your worthy cause!"

Adora forced herself to keep smiling as Priest spoke. She wanted to cringe at all the praise - she wasn't a goddess! Their lives weren't hers to command! She was… Oh, no, she was starting to think like Priest spoke! "He must have been watching a lot of Earth television," she muttered under her breath.

Of course, Catra's ears caught her words, and her lover snickered. "Mostly the competition, I think."

"The competition?" Adora whispered before scolding herself - they were on Darla's bridge; she wouldn't be overheard even if she yelled, as long as she didn't open a channel to Priest. And - she quickly checked - there was no channel open.

"What are you whispering about?" Glimmer asked.

"Priest's speech," Catra told her. "He's been watching Earth preachers."

"Yeah, some of his ramblings sounded familiar," O'Neill cut in.

"...and with renewed fervour, we shall do our utmost to spread Your words and ideals to a galaxy yearning to be free, to expose the false gods deceiving and exploiting their faithful, as the…"

"Yep, file off the numbers, and that could be coming from any televangelist on Earth." O'Neill nodded. "I wonder if they can sue him for copyright violations."

"If they do, they would open themselves for such suits, I think," Daniel said.

"They'll claim they got it straight from god," O'Neill retorted.

"Shh! Priest is about to finish!" Bow hissed.

And that meant Adora was expected to say a few words as well. She winced and went over her prepared speech while Priest finished showering his praise and devotion she didn't deserve.

"Thank you. We are facing enemies who are posing as gods to manipulate their slaves - enemies who are willing to sacrifice everything and everyone for power. They're ruthless and evil - but that is not their strength, but their weakness. This mission we are setting out now is…"

As she spoke, Adora felt like a hypocrite. She was no goddess, yet the clones worshipped her. And she was using their faith to lead them. If she were selfish and cruel, she'd be no better than the Goa'uld!

*****

Hyperspace, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

It really was weird how quickly you grew used to things that had been limited to the realms of science fiction just a few years ago, Samantha Carter thought not for the first time. Here she was, on board a spaceship travelling through hyperspace, already lightyears away from Earth, and it felt like a plane trip back on Earth. She was more concerned about passing the time productively than about the journey itself.

Fortunately, even with the new stealth shuttle taking up most of Darla's hangar space, there was still room left for her and

Entrapta's 'travelling lab', as her friend called it. It wasn't even nearly as sophisticated as their space lab, but they could do serious work anyway.

And, in a pinch, and as long Darla stayed outside hyperspace and in range of the spy bot network, they could even remotely access the space lab for some experiments. The lag was frustrating, but they could do work like that if they were careful.

Though since they were going on a recon mission, ensuring that the shuttle was in perfect working order took priority. And that included ensuring that Entrapta didn't add untested modifications during their trip. Even though they looked sound upon cursory or even in-depth examination, Sam reminded herself. *Especially* if they looked sound and fascinating.

"No, I don't think the Colonel meant that we should add a 'torpedo mode' to the shuttle," she told her friend.

"But it would let us use it as a missile if we had to - a stealth missile!"

"It would also add a Naquadah-enhanced bomb to the shuttle," Sam pointed out.

"Yes?"

Sam sighed and started to explain why that wasn't an entirely positive thing.

*****

Deep Space, Near PZ-921, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Alright! We've got the latest data from the spy bots. There was no change in the target fleet. Well, no significant change - the fleet maintained its position, and its composition didn't change, but the individual ships moved around a lot and often switched formations."

Catra nodded at Entrapta's report. Her friend was a scientist, not an officer, but the picture was obvious. "They're drilling their crews," she said.

"Yes." Adora nodded. "Can we tell from their movements what kind of action they're training for?"

"I don't know!" Entrapta beamed. "Let's review the data!" Her hair moved, and the screen on Darla's bridge showed the last movements of the target ships. "I've sped the maneuvres up by a factor of ten," she added.

Catra watched the ships circle around each other, the fleet splitting up into four parts, then joining together. "Looks like basic fleet actions," she commented. She didn't have a lot of experience with space combat, but she had studied the data from Horde Prime's fleets. And the basics were obvious. "Escort drills. Attack and retreat actions."

"Yes," Adora agreed. "So, we can't deduce what they are planning from those drills."

"They might not be planning anything yet," O'Neill pointed out. "And that's just basic drills to keep the crew busy. God knows you don't want bored soldiers on your ship. They'll just get into trouble."

"Jaffa are generally more disciplined than that, O'Neill," Teal'c objected. "It is more likely that this is to keep their skills sharp." He cocked his head slightly to the side. "They are changing formations and reacting to orders more smoothly compared to the average Goa'uld fleet. These Jaffa are skilled and experienced."

"We don't know if that is a Goa'uld fleet," Daniel said. "They could be… renegades. Or pirates."

O'Neill snorted. "Pirates, Daniel? Really?"

Daniel flushed. "Well… We do know that there are, well, Goa'uld who deserted their System Lord. And not just those who joined

the Tok’ra. It’s not a stretch to assume that they would resort to raiding others to sustain their forces. If no other System Lord will take them in, that is.”

“Few of the false gods would take in another Goa’uld who abandoned their lord.” Teal’c inclined his head.

“Why?” Glimmer asked. “Don’t they expect their underlings to betray them at every opportunity?”

“Yes. However, anyone who shelters such a deserter might make the System Lord suspect that they were behind the desertion in the first place - or give them the excuse to claim so and act in retribution without appearing to be the attacker,” Teal’c explained.

Catra snorted. “And the other System Lords care about such pretexts even though they’ll know it’s a sham.”

“Indeed.”

“Don’t fail your snake overlord. And if you do, don’t get caught.” O’Neill shrugged. “But that’s a sizeable fleet for a deserter. Even for a guy like Her’ur, that wouldn’t be a negligible loss. What are the odds that so many Jaffa would follow a deserting System Lord?”

“Low,” Teal’c replied. “Most of the false gods know better than to leave a subordinate to gain the loyalty of so many Jaffa. The most probable explanation would be that there was a successful coup against a System Lord, and this fleet is the loyalist remnant of their forces.”

That made sense. But wouldn’t the Tok’ra have heard of that?

“If that is the case, this would present an opportunity,” Hordak said. “Such a survivor would likely be willing to share crucial intel about their enemies. For support - or merely out of spite.” He glanced at Catra, and she met his eyes.

He must be thinking about her own coup against him - if you could call that mess a coup. It wasn't as if it had been planned.

"And because of their genetic memory, if they were toppled by one of their descendants, they could share a lot of information," Daniel added.

"But we couldn't trust them," Glimmer said. "Dethroned or not, they're still a Goa'uld. They would be trying to manipulate us - and betray us at the first opportunity."

"Maybe the second opportunity." Catra grinned. "They would probably suspect the first to be a trap."

A few of the others snickered in response to that.

"But what do we do if a Goa'uld asks for protection? Or asylum?" Bow asked.

"Tell them to get lost," O'Neill said.

Catra snorted, but he wasn't wrong in her opinion.

"If someone asks for asylum, we'll take them in and check if they are genuine," Adora said with a frown. "That's the least we can do - although we'll take all necessary precautions to ensure it's not a trap."

"And then? Play nice with the evil body-snatching snake?" O'Neill narrowed his eyes slightly. "What about their victims? What about their hosts?"

Catra pressed her lips together and looked at the screen instead of at anyone else. That was… a bit too close for comfort.

"We'll check how genuine they are," Adora repeated herself. "And if they are willing to change. And they have to release their host, unless they have voluntarily chosen to host them."

"Fat chance of that." O'Neill scoffed.

"If they aren't genuinely willing to change, we don't have any obligation to help or protect them. So, given how Goa'uld are…" Glimmer trailed off. "But we can't dismiss the possibility of a Goa'uld honestly defecting. The Tok'ra show that this is possible."

Catra nodded, still not looking at anyone. Not even Adora.

After a moment of silence, Adora spoke up again: "So, let's go and find out who is in command of that fleet and what they want."

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Deep Space, Near Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill stared out of the windows on Darla's bridge at the yellowish star in the distance - conveniently highlighted by a holoprojection from the ship, in case he somehow might miss the brightest star nearby. Sometimes the ship's system - whether it was actually intelligent, as Entrapta claimed, or just a sophisticated computer program, as Carter thought - was a bit patronising. "It'll probably start calculating my caloric needs next," Jack muttered.

"What did you say, Jack?" Adora asked.

"Nothing," he told her. "Just a stray thought." A silly stray thought.

"Afraid you'll grow fat on our cooking?" Catra, of course, had overheard his comment perfectly despite being farther away than Adora. She was smirking, too - her ears were turned towards him, and her tail was slowly swishing back and forth. Lazily, not nervously - Jack had learned the difference by now.

And wasn't that a weird thing to know? He felt like a crazy cat lady. Although the agencies back home probably had recruited a bunch of biologists and a few crazy cat ladies just to analyse Catra's behaviour. And Jack couldn't fault them; the catwoman was not only Adora's lover, which meant she had a huge influence on the Alliance's strategy and policy, but she was a leader in her

own right. Although didn't have a loyal cadre of followers or subjects - as far as Jack knew, at least. But if they ever found a planet where the population worshipped cats, that might change…

He snorted at the thought, then shook his head. "Just thinking about the fact that the Ancient Egyptians worshipped cats. Amongst other things."

"So I've heard. They had good taste," Catra said, her grin widening.

"Except for worshipping the Goa'uld, of course," Glimmer cut in.

Catra shrugged. "Well, the snakes impersonated their gods, so how could they tell the difference?"

"It's actually not quite clear if the Goa'uld impersonated existing gods when they discovered Earth or if they created the Egyptian pantheon - and other pantheons - in the first place," Daniel said. "It might be a combination of the two possibilities; the first Goa'uld arrivals coopting existing deities and taking over their churches and others creating their own cults."

"Didn't you ask Osiris about that?" Bow asked. "He was amongst the first Goa'uld to arrive, wasn't he? And Seth as well?"

That was actually a good question. Jack glanced at his friend.

"Well… Osiris claimed that they created the pantheon, and with it, the Egyptian civilisation," Daniel replied. "But I have my doubts about that."

"Why? What could he gain by lying?" Bow asked.

"Feeling important?" Jack said, shrugging. "Being the founder of human civilisation would be quite the feather in his cap." The snake might even hope that it would get him a pardon or something. Or followers.

“Yes.” Daniel nodded. “And it would, well, wouldn’t call it a threat to our world’s culture, but if the cradle of human civilisation was formed by the Goa’uld, that would change history as we know it - more than their arrival being revealed already did, of course - and the ramifications of a huge part of human culture being created by aliens…”

“At least no one’s worshipping the Egyptian gods any more,” Jack commented. “Imagine people demanding that we free their gods on the grounds of religious freedom!” He chuckled. That would be something.

But Daniel nodded and pushed his glasses up. “Well, some of the pagan gods clearly influenced the Abrahamic god. Or, to be more precise, their myths influenced the myths that became the Bible. And while the dogma of the Abrahamic religions that there is only one god has been solidified for well over a thousand years by now, from a purely scholarly point of view, the extent of Goa’uld influence on existing religions really should be researched.”

“Yeah,” Jack said with a slight scoff, “‘Hey, your religion was invented by alien snakes’ is going to go over really well with people. I can’t see any problem with that.”

Daniel flushed. “Well, one has to differentiate between religious and historical questions.”

“So, does that mean that all the fake gods went extinct after the Goa’uld left Earth?” Adora asked.

“More or less,” Jack told her.

“Not quite,” Daniel protested. “Some of the gods that the Goa’uld impersonated are still worshipped on Earth. Like Raiden.”

“Yeah, we heard about them,” Catra said. “Are their followers going to be a security risk?”

“Some might be,” Jack admitted. “If they thought the Goa’uld were their original god. But they should know better than that if

they were in the Alliance." Though he was sure that the spooks were keeping an eye on soldiers who might turn traitors for religious reasons.

"That's exactly the reason why we need to know more about that time," Daniel said. "We need to know if the Goa'uld created or coopted the ancient religions."

And if the former was true, they would have to decide if they revealed that - or buried that in the deepest vault they could find. Not that Jack was about to mention that to Daniel. This wasn't the time to discuss religion, scientific integrity and political expediency.

They had a mission to do. And they were wasting time. "Well, hate to cut this short," Jack said. "But we're in position to launch the mission now."

Recon now, religion later. Or not at all, if Jack had anything to say about it.

*****

Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Approaching the limit of the safe distance."

Adora wet her lips at Jack's announcement. This was it. So far, they had been safely out of the sensor range of the Goa'uld, adjusted for their craft's sensor signature, but that would change now. Of course, there were some safety margins, so it wasn't as if they were undetectable one moment and would appear the next, and they couldn't be a hundred per cent sure about the sensor capability of the ships ahead of them, but still - she couldn't help feeling a little nervous.

"Engaging active stealth system!" Entrapa sounded cheerful. She would be - she loved showing and using new technology. Not as much as she loved creating it, of course.

The stars outside vanished. For a moment, Adora was reminded of Etheria before it had been returned to the universe. There hadn't been any stars back then, either. But there had been the sun and the moons. Not a complete absence of… anything.

The screens still showed the same pictures, though - the sensors, except for the optical sensors, weren't affected by the light being bent around them. And in space, you rarely used your naked eyes to navigate, anyway - at least not in a ship. Still, it felt a little off.

"No change in the target fleet," Sam reported.

"They haven't detected us," Glimmer nodded with a smile.

"Well, we're still at a distance where they might not have detected us even without the active stealth system," Bow pointed out. "They might still do so when we fly closer."

"And if they're smart, they won't react at all until we're too close to avoid their response," Catra added. She was sitting next to Adora, one hand on the armrest of Adora's seat, clearly tense - her tail was swishing back and forth rapidly.

"That would require specific standing orders," Teal'c said. "To see an enemy approaching and not react at once would usually see a warrior severely chastised. As a rule, the false gods do not value such initiative or cunning by their forces."

Jack snorted. "Let's hope that the mystery fleet is doing things by the book, then."

Adora nodded. But the fleet ahead of them was already acting weird - for Goa'uld, at least. What were the odds they had different standard procedures? Well, they'd find out. And if it was a trap… well, Priest's task force was ready to jump in at a moment's notice, with enough ships to overwhelm the target fleet. All Adora would have to do was keep the shuttle safe until then.

"We're now approaching the red zone," Jack's voice rang out. He didn't sound nervous at all even though they were now reaching

the range where they knew they would be detected in a normal shuttle.

“Enemy sensor activity nominal.”

That meant the sensor sweeps hadn’t increased or changed focus, Adora translated Sam’s report. A good sign - if the sensors picked up a signal from the shuttle, they would do a second, more focused sweep to confirm the hit.

“They still haven’t noticed us,” Catra said.

“Don’t sound so disappointed,” Glimmer commented.

“I’m not.”

“Passive sensors working as intended!” Entrapta smiled. “We’re getting new data! We haven’t been so close before! Oh, I hope the spy bots won’t grow jealous!”

“They’ll get over it,” Catra said. “Without them, we wouldn’t have found the fleet in the first place.”

“Right! I’ll tell them that! It should cheer them up!”

“I thought the spy drones were not sapient?” Daniel sounded confused.

“They still have feelings!” Entapta told him.

“Sensor data is being updated,” Sam interrupted them.

Adora checked her screen. “Do we have any ship names yet?” Without optical sensors, they would have to get really close to discern different paint coats to make out any letters.

“Not yet. But the passive scans of the traditional locations for ship names show recent work on the surface,” Sam told her.

“They renamed the ships - or erased any names,” Catra said.

“Either would indicate subterfuge rather than open battle as their goal,” Teal’c commented.

“And that they have taken steps to hide their identity.” Catra flashed her fangs.

“Or they captured or acquired the ships and renamed them,” Daniel pointed out.

Catra scowled. “And then they hide out like this?”

“Well, if they stole the ships…” Daniel trailed off, looking a bit embarrassed.

“If they stole those ships, odds are they’re willing to do it again,” Jack said.

“We’re in range of the magitech scanner!” Entrapta quivered in her seat. “Let’s see what we find out!”

The screens changed as the sensor readings updated.

“Those are the markings of Apophis,” Teal’c said in a flat voice. “But we know that he masked his ships when he sent them at Heru’ur.”

“Could be a double bluff. He might attempt another attack and claim someone’s impersonating his forces,” Bow suggested. “Make it appear as if they were recently renamed by renaming them himself!”

“That is unlikely.” Teal’c shook his head. “The false god has a tendency to enact complicated plans, but he would not act without more information about the situation at hand.”

“He might have gotten the ships ready while he’s looking for more information?” Bow didn’t sound as if he believed that himself.

“The ships he lost in the attack on Heru’ur that we foiled represent a respectable force. While he is not crippled, his mobile

reserve has been weakened, and hiding another force would make him look weaker than he is, inviting raids and probing attacks from his rivals." Teal'c shook his head again. "I doubt that this force belongs to Apophis."

"And you're our expert on him. Good enough for me," Jack said. "But if it's not Apophis, who else could it be? Someone with a beef against him?"

That could be any System Lord, Adora knew. "We'll have to find out," she said.

"Unfortunately, it looks like we'll have to actually board one ship to do that."

Jack didn't sound disappointed, though, Adora noted. Well, she wasn't disappointed either.

It would be good to be able to do something in person.

*****

Samantha Carter glanced at the main screen on the bridge of the shuttle. They were closing in on the Goa'uld fleet - the suspected Goa'uld fleet, she corrected herself. Even though she had no doubt that the fleet was controlled by a Goa'uld. They were almost at point-blank range now, but the Goa'uld ships had not changed their patterns. If the enemy's sensors were able to penetrate the stealth system of the shuttle, they would have done so long ago.

There was still a chance that this was a trap, that the fleet was just waiting for them to fly too close to evade an attack, but Sam had her doubts about that. Not because of a gut feeling, as the Colonel would claim, but because, as Teal'c had explained, it was very unlikely for a Goa'uld force to react like that. Unless, of course, they were aware of their mission from the start or expected such a mission, but either was extremely unlikely.

“Still no change in the enemy’s sensor activity,” Entrapta commented. “The stealth system is working perfectly!” She beamed. “Well, it’s drawing a little bit more power than projected, but nothing the shuttle’s reactor can’t handle.”

Sam checked the readings. Indeed, the system was running a bit less efficiently than expected. Although that wasn’t really worrying - as her friend had said, they had power to spare. Of course, should they have to fight as well, that might change, but even then, the discrepancy was unlikely to prove crucial. A few more shots from the ship’s cannons wouldn’t decide a battle with a fleet.

But they still hadn’t found out who the fleet belonged to. And that was the mission’s goal. “Any sign of a sensor network?” she asked.

“No,” Entrapta replied. “The ships haven’t linked their sensors and aren’t sharing data. Unless they discovered a method to transmit data that we can’t detect. Do you think they did?”

Sam shook her head. They had picked up some transmissions before - if the unknown masters of the fleet had discovered a superior communication method, they would have been using it for all their comms. That was the logical response. Unless it was limited to certain ships, but in that case, the communications with the other ships should reveal such a pattern. It wasn’t tightbeams - they had checked for that. While the shuttle’s system wouldn’t be able to intercept such communications unless they were directly between two ships, they should be able to detect such a network. But there wasn’t any.

It seemed that the fleet still adhered to strict comm discipline. And that meant they couldn’t hack the system. There was the possibility of hijacking the sensors, but… Sam wasn’t optimistic about their chances. And even if that worked, the compromised system might not have links to the main computers of the ship.

“No luck hacking the snakes?”

Sam schooled her features, not letting her annoyance at her failure show as she looked at the Colonel. “No, sir. Whoever those crews are, they practise good cyber security.”

“Yes!” Entrapta chimed in. “We’ll have to find a main communication hub to hack into, I think. Like we did with Horde Prime’s systems. Those were a challenge.”

The Colonel grinned. “So, how do we do this without alerting the snakes?”

They had gone over that in the briefings. “We’ll have to match speed with the target ship and then stay close enough so we can use our spacesuits for EVA without getting detected.”

That would have to be very close. They couldn’t touch the Goa’uld ship, though - sensors fooled or not, the crew wouldn’t miss the sound and shock of a shuttle setting down on the ship.

“Well, let’s pick a target then.” The Colonel was undaunted.

“I would suggest this one, sir.” Sam highlighted a Ha’tak on the main screen. “Based on our data of their communications, such as we could gather, this is either a flagship or a communication hub. Either way, its systems should contain the information we need.”

“And the movement patterns it has displayed so far should make staying near it easier than, say, near an Al’kesh,” Entrapta added.

The Colonel looked at Entrapta, then glanced at Sam, raising his eyebrows.

“The ship only very rarely made unexpected changes to its speed or course,” Sam explained.

“Ah.” He nodded. “Good. Let’s go, then.”

They were already suited up. And, even more important, they had already hashed out who would be on the boarding team and who would stay on the shuttle.

Though, Sam couldn't help thinking as she disconnected her laptop from its cradle in her seat and Bow moved to take over the ship's helm, the criteria for deciding the latter might not have been very objective. Bow had simply been the most amiable to staying behind. Or, in other words, hadn't insisted as forcefully as everyone else that he should be on the boarding team.

Sam felt a little guilty for that herself, but she was a logical choice for any such mission since she could hack Goa'uld computer systems. Unlike, say, Daniel, who somehow had managed to argue successfully that he could interpret cultural clues during the mission. Or Glimmer, who had simply insisted that she had experience with such missions and pretty much dared anyone else to contradict her.

Well, the decisions had been made.

Sam slipped her helmet on, checked the seals and ran a brief system check as she stepped into the shuttle's cargo area. It was time to do her job.

*****

"Alright, here we go…"

Catra tensed as she heard O'Neill speak. They were at the critical point - the final approach to the enemy flagship. If this was a trap… No, the Goa'ld would have shot at them before that.

"And here we are, nice and smooth, right behind the big sucker. Han Solo got nothing on this! You've got the craft, Bow."

"I've got the craft."

Her ears picked up rapid steps - O'Neill was hustling towards the cargo area. "We won't start without you," she commented as he reached them.

"Didn't want to make you wait any longer," he replied. He was already wearing the helmet, so she assumed he was ready for the

boarding.

The hatch closed behind him, and she heard the whining noise as the air was sucked out of the room. The shuttle had a dedicated airlock, but it was too small for the entire group - it was too small for just the BFS, actually; Scorpia would probably fill it up by herself if she were here - so they had to use the cargo area for that.

But whatever worked, worked. A moment later, the ramp opened in front of her. Catra felt her fur bristle - looking at the stealth field was disturbing. It was like staring at the deepest black. Not even a speck of light or smidge of grey was visible, just perfect blackness.

And they would have to jump through it to reach the enemy Ha'tak.

She clenched her teeth - she wouldn't show any nervousness. This was just an illusion, nothing more. A trick of the eyes. Whatever. She tapped a button on the side of her helmet, linking up with the shuttle's sensors, and a view of the outside was projected into her field of vision. She could see part of the Ha'tak's hull in front of her now.

"Looks good," O'Neill commented, prompting her to snort. As if he was as cool as he sounded. "Carter?"

"One last scan… we're in the blind spot of their sensors, sir. We're good to go. Highlighting possible points of entry."

Two airlocks lit up on Catra's display.

"Let's take the closer one. Less walking." Catra wouldn't let O'Neill outdo her.

"Sounds good. Wouldn't want to make Bow wait too long for us."

"Oh, I'm fine."

Catra shook her head. “Let’s go.” She took a step forward, to the top of the ramp - which opened into nothing.

“I’ll go first.” Adora passed her before she could protest and jumped off.

Catra hissed under her breath when she saw Adora vanish in the stealth field. Then she crouched and jumped after her lover. Into the darkness.

It wasn’t as she had expected. She didn’t pass through complete darkness for what felt like an eternity. No, one moment, she was flying towards a black field, the next, she was about to land on the golden hull of the Ha’tak, the projection aligning with the real deal at once.

She twisted and landed on all fours on it, the magnets in her gloves and boots sticking her to the metal. Adora was just a bit to the side, crouching on the hull herself. Still in her spacesuit, which was a good sign - if she had to transform, things would have gone wrong already. And She-Ra’s power would probably light up all the sensors of the Goa’uld.

And behind her… was nothing. She knew where the shuttle was, but she couldn’t see it, just its projection inside her helmet.

Another figure appeared from nowhere. O’Neill, landing with reasonable grace on the hull, followed by Sam and Glimmer.

Daniel came next - and he almost smashed headfirst into the ship, but Entrapta’s hair grabbed him at the last second.

“Thank you,”

“No worries!” Entrapta landed on the hull, then put Daniel down.

Teal’c brought up the rear, landing smoothly in a crouch without comment.

Sam was already at the airlock, tools out, and Entrapta quickly joined her, hair tendrils pulling her across the hull while she floated in space.

Catra looked around while her friends worked on the hatch. She could see another Ha'tak in the distance, barely more than a tiny pyramid, and some moving lights drew her attention - Al'keshs, or maybe Tel'taks. Or Death Gliders that were closer than she thought. She cycled through the sensor overlay from the shuttle to check. Al'keshs, at a safe distance. Good.

It took Sam and Entrapta half a minute to open the hatch. Adora entered right away, but Catra had expected that and slipped into the airlock behind her, followed by Sam. And, of course, O'Neill just had to follow her.

It was a bit cramped as a result. Sam almost buried her elbow in Catra's stomach when she used her laptop, but Catra twisted out of the way, pressing herself into Adora's side.

"I've spoofed the security cameras," Sam reported twenty seconds later.

Then the airlock cycled, and the inner hatch opened. Ador went left, Catra right, stun rod at the ready to deal with any Jaffa present.

But the hallway was clear. And rather plain.

"Doesn't look very fancy," O'Neill commented. "Where's all the gold and glitter?"

"It's a maintenance conduct," Sam told him.

"Too bad. I would have liked a big VIP entrance, complete with huge golden hieroglyphs that said: 'Welcome to the flagship of System Lord X'."

"Such an entrance would usually be heavily guarded even when no guests were expected," Teal'c pointed out over the comm as

the hatch closed again.

"Yeah, but at least we'd know who we were shooting then," O'Neill retorted.

"How about we don't shoot anyone?" Daniel suggested. *"We're here to find out what's going on, not to shoot things."*

"We can multitask," O'Neill said. "Besides, I bet we're going to shoot them later anyway, so might as well start early."

Catra chuckled as the others entered the ship as well, but her ears were twitching. Was that…? Yes. "Someone's approaching!" she hissed. She crouched down, pressing herself against the wall. "Just one person," she whispered - she couldn't hear any other steps.

The others stepped into alcoves or crouched down, close to the walls - taking cover as best as they could in the corridor. Even Adora - Catra had half-expected her to transform into She-Ra at the first sign of potential trouble.

But they couldn't hide. And they couldn't leave through the airlock quickly enough to avoid getting spotted - or overheard.

The steps had come even closer. The person was now just around the corner. Catra tensed, ready to pounce, take down the target, silence them before they could scream and alert the rest of the crew, and…

The steps stopped.

Catra blinked. What the…?

Then she heard the sound of a bag being opened, and then metal clashing against metal, followed by muttering. When she smelt heated metal, she almost sighed. Whoever was around the corner was doing repairs or maintenance there.

She could easily take them down - they were too close to react to her rounding the corner, they were distracted by their work, and Catra knew how to knock out someone. But even if they took the prisoner with them afterwards, the ship's crew would be looking for him. And given their strict security measures, they would likely suspect enemy action - and react accordingly.

Which would ruin part of the mission's goal. Damn. She clenched her teeth and glanced back at the others.

Adora was smiling apologetically, as if this complication was her fault. Glimmer was scowling, Sam and Entrapta looked focused and curious, respectively, Teal'c showed no reaction at all, and O'Neill… was grinning.

Catra shook her head - softly. On the one hand, if they took a prisoner, they would be able to find out who was behind this. Sure, a maintenance flunkie wouldn't know their plans, but they would know general orders. And past deployments. And if they were some System Lord's fleet, the Alliance would probably destroy them anyway, so whether or not they were put on alert wouldn't matter. Although that wouldn't tell them the enemy's plans either. And if the ships had slaves on them… They had most certainly killed slaves when they had destroyed the ships of Apophis attacking PZ-921, but they hadn't had much of a choice there - not with the enemy fighting to the death and even self-destructing in some cases. But here? Adora would want to attempt a rescue, and revealing their presence would endanger that.

So they could wait for the idiot to finish their work and leave, or go the other way - and hope the idiot wouldn't follow them.

Decisions, decisions.

Catra glanced over her shoulder again. O'Neill moved his hand, pointing to the ground in the 'wait' sign. But she looked at Adora. That was her call.

And Adora nodded.

So, waiting it was.

And the minutes passed. Whoever was working around the corner wasn't the fastest technician in the fleet. Or the most careful - they cursed quite a lot, if not loud. Catra might not understand the language, but she knew a curse when she heard it. But, really! Kyle would have done a better job!

But finally, after almost twenty minutes, Catra heard a satisfied grunt, followed by metal tools touching each other. The idiot was done! As soon as they left, Catra could…

The steps were headed their way! Catra gasped and started moving forward. She crashed into the other person as they rounded the corner, bowling them over. One hand stopped them from screaming, the other rammed the shock rod into their chest.

The man - the Jaffa! - convulsed, and before he could recover, O'Neill zatted him.

Catra pulled the Jaffa fully back around the corner, just in case, then looked him over. Light armour, a big tool bag, a zat at his hip. "A Jaffa engineer?" she asked.

"Well…" O'Neill started to say, but Teal'c cut him off, pointing at the symbol on the man's chest.

"Sokar."

Oh. The fleet belonged to the System Lord whom Apophis had planned to frame with his false flag attack.

That complicated things.

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Scouting Part 2

Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Looks like dear old Sokar found out that Apophis wanted to frame him and decided to return the favour," Jack O'Neill commented while he quickly patted the unconscious prisoner down. They had his zat and toolbag, but Jack was sure that… Ah! He pulled a small knife from the Jaffa's boot, followed by some wire and tweezers. And various other thingies that Jack didn't recognise but the guy obviously worked with. And they wouldn't want the guy to go all A-Team on them and construct a death ray in his cell using his boots and the breakfast porridge.

"OK, we've got a prisoner and a name. Let's take him with us and leave before someone notices that he's missing," Catra said. "Even Kyle couldn't take forever for a simple repair job."

"But we don't know what the fleet's orders are," Entrapta protested. "We need to hack the computer system for that!"

She was correct, of course - just knowing the identity of the fleet was the bare minimum they could achieve. And not nearly as valuable as finding out what Sokar was planning. But the longer they stayed on the ship, the greater the risk of being detected. As tight as these Jaffa ran their ships, with their cyber security and radio silence, they wouldn't let a maintenance flunkie skive off from work. Which meant time was running out as they spoke.

He glanced at Carter. She hadn't said anything, but she looked determined. Confident. And she wasn't looking at the airlock - she was looking forward at the corner leading into the main part of the ship.

And yet… He looked at Teal'c. "What are the chances that Sokar will assume the fleet's cover's been blown should a jaffa go missing on his ship?"

Teal’c cocked his head to the side. “It is hard to say, but System Lords always expect treachery. If we take the strict discipline and security into account that we have observed in this fleet, I think he would assume the worst until he could find out what had happened to the missing Jaffa.”

“And that means any intel we might find would be obsolete. Mostly obsolete,” Jack corrected himself - it would still give them insight into the snake’s strategic goals if they knew his target. But then, they already knew that Apophis was to be framed. He nodded. “Let’s not push our luck. We can always…”

A harsh voice in a language Jack didn’t speak sounded from the ship’s PA system, finishing with a short, barking laugh.

He looked at Daniel.

“Uh… the person asked, quite rudely, if ‘Manut’u’ has accidentally discharged his zat’nik’tel again and promised dire punishment if he did,” Daniel said.

Shit! Jack clenched his teeth. “We need to leave now! They detected me stunning him.” Stupid. He should have been more careful - especially on an unknown ship.

“But…” Entrapta tried to protest, but Catra grabbed her arm and dragged her towards the airlock.

“No time! We need to leave!”

Teal’c had already picked up their prisoner and thrown him over his shoulder before hauling ass.

“Daniel! Go!” Jack snapped, holstering his zat and grabbing his carbine. “Carter! You too!” he added as he covered the hallway ahead of them.

Neither protested.

Teal’c had just finished stuffing the prisoner into the airlock, after Entrapta, Daniel, and Carter, when Jack arrived.

“You too, Glimmer!” Catra added - she was covering the other hallway with Adora.

“What?”

“You’re the smallest.”

To Jack’s surprise, Glimmer squeezed herself into the airlock without even a token protest about Catra being more flexible or something. Jack hit the controls, and the hatch closed.

A few seconds later, it had cycled, and they could hear the outer hatch open.

“One down, one to go,” Jack muttered as he kept aiming his carbine down the maintenance duct.

“Hatch closed, sir,” Carter reported over their comms.

“Good. Get back to the shuttle!” Jack hit the controls again.

The hatch didn’t move.

And the PA system rang out again.

Jack didn’t need to be a linguist to know that this was an alert.

“They’ve made us!” he snapped. “The hatch’s locked!”

And both their hackers were on the other side of the airlock - probably back in the shuttle already.

“I’ll be back in a second to override it, sir!”

“No! Stay in the shuttle! We’ll blow the hatch open!” Jack retorted.

“No need.” Catra grinned and unsheathed her claws.

A few swipes later, the inner hatch was reduced to a heap of scrap on the floor. Right. Jack had forgotten that Catra made a great Wolverine impression with her claws.

"Watch out when you do the outer hatch," he cautioned her. "We don't want an explosive decompression." That would suck - literally.

Catra chuckled as she stepped into the airlock. "Don't worry."

But as she reached out to shred the outer hatch, presumably just enough to let the air out, the whole ship shuddered - in a familiar way. "Hold it!" he snapped.

But she had already stopped - and tapped her helmet. "Glimmer? Bow? Entrapta?"

No answer.

"Carter?" Jack added.

Still no answer. And they were wearing Entrapta's special spacesuits, using her special comm. The snakes didn't know about that, so they couldn't jam it. That left…

"It seems the ship has entered hyperspace," Teal'c said.

"Shit."

*****

Hyperspace, Near Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

They were in hyperspace. Separated from their friends. Adora could only hope that the shuttle was OK. If the Goa'uld had detected and shot at it, at point-blank range… No. They would have noticed the guns firing, wouldn't they? And their friends would have said something, before… And the Ha'tak wouldn't

have jumped into hyperspace if they had destroyed the shuttle. Or just detected it.

That was it. Adora nodded firmly. Their friends were fine. They had to worry about themselves now. She glanced at Catra.

"They know we're here," her lover said. She cocked her head. "And I can hear them coming from this direction." She pointed to the right. "Fight or flight?"

"We can take them," Adora said. If she transformed into She-Ra, this would be easy.

"But if they realise that, they might decide to blow the ship up to take us with them," Jack pointed out. "And not everyone here is explosion-proof."

"Let's avoid them then. This way!" Catra started heading left.

Adora winced as they quickly ran down the hallway. That was a risk she hadn't considered - and she should have. If the Jaffa decided to suicide…

After a few corners, they stopped. Jack looked at Teal'c. "You know this ship best. Where can we hole up?"

"This way should lead to store rooms and magazines," Teal'c said, taking the lead.

They ran down another narrow hallway.

"Stop!" Catra hissed. "I hear people ahead."

"In here!" Jack pushed a door open.

It was a storage room. Adora pressed herself against the wall next to the door. If the enemy found them, she'd face them first.

Catra remained at the other side of the doorway. Jack and Teal'c hid behind crates, weapons ready.

Adora saw Catra's ears twist. "They're coming this way," her lover whispered. "Almost here."

Adora held her breath. If they checked the room… She tensed and got ready to transform, flexing her hand - she could call her sword in an instant, just thinking about it.

Seconds passed. Was that a noise outside? Adora licked her lips.

Catra remained tense.

More seconds passed.

And Adora's lover nodded. "They're gone."

Whew! Adora relaxed. A little. "So, what now?" she asked, looking at the others.

"We need to destroy their hyperdrive," Catra said. "Before we end up who knows where. Probably at Sokar's headquarters."

Adora nodded in agreement. "And we need to contact our friends so they can come fetch us."

"And we need to prevent the crew from blowing themselves up. Or telling the other ships, if they are around, to destroy them and us," Jack added.

"If we destroy the hyperdrive and drop out of hyperspace, they'll have a fun time trying to find us," Catra said, grinning.

Adroa pressed her lips together. It was a dangerous plan - destroying the hyperdrive in hyperspace could seriously damage the ship. But it shouldn't destroy it. At least not a ship the size of a Ha'tak. And it was probably the safest solution.

The others seemed to agree - Jack nodded, and Teal'c… didn't say anything against the suggestion.

“So, we’ll have to be sneaky. We can’t just cut our way through them to the engine room and the bridge. As satisfying as that would be, that would spook them, and they might blow themselves up.” Catra flashed her fangs in that confident grin of hers that… Ah, not the time, Adora reminded herself. Catra looked at Teal’c. “Are they likely to do that?”

Teal’c inclined his head. “According to what I was told, Sokar was feared by even his most loyal followers. They believe that he will condemn them to eternal torment in the afterlife should they fail him.”

“What a nice guy. Did he ever hear about catching more flies with honey than vinegar?” Jack shook his head.

Catra shrugged. “Doesn’t sound so different from some of those preachers of yours talking about hell.”

Adora frowned at her lover. She remembered those people saying that she would go to hell for loving Catra, but this wasn’t the time to discuss religion. “So, we need to take control of the engine room and the bridge. And probably the ordnance magazines as well.”

“Without getting noticed while the entire crew of the ship is looking for us,” Catra added. “And while they are still hurrying in the hope of catching us in the open, they will soon stop and start going through every room.” She looked up at the ventilation duct. “I wish Entrapta was here. She’d be able to reach everywhere in the ship through the ducts.”

“And Carter would be able to hack their system to hide us,” Jack added. “But we’re currently lacking our technological geniuses, so we have to make do with brawn and base cunning.” He grinned. “Teal’c, I don’t suppose you would have memorised a Ha’tak’s air duct layout?”

“I have not, O’Neill. However, they follow a basic layout dictated by the ship’s core design, so, unless Sokar has had this ship

modified on a fundamental level - which is unlikely - we should still be able to navigate a path to our destination."

"Great! Let's hope dear old Sokar wasn't even more paranoid than we think."

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Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

The Ha'tak had entered hyperspace. With the Colonel, Teal'c, Adora and Catra still on board. Because Samantha Carter had failed to be thorough when she had hacked the airlock, and so the Goa'uld or Jaffa in charge of the ship had managed to override her commands and lock it down. If Sam had taken a bit more time, had been a bit more careful, hadn't simply assumed that overriding the manual commands would be enough, this wouldn't have happened.

This was her fault.

And now the Colonel and the others were stuck on a Goa'uld ship, travelling through hyperspace to an unknown destination. Stuck without a tech expert. That was Sam's fault as well. She should have stayed back with the Colonel, in case something like this happened, and had let one of the others go with the prisoners. Maybe Teal'c - though he might not have fit into the airlock; it had been very tight already. Catra would have fit, though, in place of Sam. Not that she would have left without Adora, though. Adora would have fit as well, as long as she wasn't transformed into She-Ra, but she wouldn't have left without Catra. And the Colonel wouldn't have left before everyone else.

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath. She could blame herself later; she had a job to do. She had to find out where that ship was going. Glancing towards Entrapta, she asked: "Did you finish compiling the data from the sensors?" If they could compute the vector of the ship when it entered hyperspace with enough precision, they could extrapolate the ship's route. That

would give them at least a direction in which they could start searching. And based on a Ha'tak's performance, they could approximately define the point where it would exit hyperspace to check their position and prepare the next jump. If they were quick enough with the calculation and could vector the spy bots nearby in to lay down a sensor net, then, taking the Horde hyperdrive's superior performance into account, they had a chance to catch the Ha'tak there. A small chance, even if everything went perfectly, but… a small chance was better than no chance at all.

"Uh… the system is still working on it. With most of the free system resources allocated to the stealth system, it's going slow," Entrapta replied. "We could reassign some of the computing power the stealth system uses, but…"

"Don't even think about that!" Bow snapped from the bridge. "Sorry," he added a moment later, "but we've got dozens of Death Gliders and Tel'taks looking for us, with Al'keshs and Ha'taks moving in as well. We need all the power routed to the stealth system until we're clear of them."

"Right!" Entrapta nodded, then turned to Sam. "I think we underestimated the drain on the ship's computing resources for our stealth system."

"It can't be helped," Sam replied. It was a weakness - but without constant recalibration and adjustments, the minuscule delays resulting from the light being bent around the shuttle might get detected by an enemy using integrated sensor networks looking for such discrepancies. They didn't know if the Goa'uld had such a network, but they certainly had the capability to form one. In theory. And as much as Sam wanted to assign every single computer core and crystal matrix to analysing the data they had, to find the Colonel and the others, she knew that they couldn't risk being discovered.

They could call in Priest's task force, of course. They would make short work of the enemy fleet. But if Sam's plan failed - and the odds for that were better than even - then they would have to

find out the missing Ha'tak's destination from the remaining ships here. And, since Sokar obviously was paranoid about security, if overcome in battle, the Jaffa would wipe their databanks and probably commit suicide before getting boarded or captured.

Of course, as the distance between the shuttle and the enemy ships grew, the risk of being detected shrank, and so it would be safe to reduce the resources for it and free them for Sam's task…

She checked the sensor readings. Maybe dropping one core and one matrix would be safe…

"Uh-oh."

That was Bow. And he sounded concerned. Sam checked the sensors - no enemy ship was close. So…

"Priest's calling us," Bow said.

"Or Hordak! They must have noticed our target moving away," Entrapta said. "Oh, maybe we can outsource some computing?"

That was… well, it should work - it would add a delay, but with the power of a frigate's mainframe at their disposal…

"So, who's going to tell Priest that Adora just vanished with an enemy ship and that it wasn't our fault?" Glimmer asked.

"Uh…" Bow sounded concerned. "He's not going to like that."

Sam felt her stomach drop as she shook her head. "No, he won't." Maybe Daniel could handle this… but he was busy looking over their prisoner. And it wouldn't be fair to drop this on him when it was Sam's fault. At least partially.

"Shouldn't he trust Adora to, well, vanquish her enemies?" Entrapta asked. "He thinks she is a goddess, after all - and while I still haven't figured out what the exact Earth definition of a goddess is - you guys have so many of them, and they don't really

fit each other - Adora should be able to handle the crew of a ship."

"That's a logical assumption," Sam told her. "But…"

"People aren't rational, right?" Entrapta sighed as Sam nodded. "Things would be so much easier if they were."

Sam nodded again.

*****

Hyperspace, Near Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Sokar hadn't been paranoid enough to replace and reroute the entire ventilation system. But he had been paranoid - or smart - enough to add grates to key locations in the ventilation ducts, blocking their passage. Grates linked to sensors, so you couldn't just slice them to pieces with your claws and continue on your way.

Fortunately, Sokar might have been paranoid, but also cheap - or operating on a budget - so the sensors were not really sophisticated. No motion or heat sensors - then again, that probably wouldn't have been a good idea in a ventilation duct where smaller objects swept along by the air currents, or hot air from somewhere, was common. Just some sensors to check if the grate was still intact. And Catra knew from her cadet days how to deal with that stuff without triggering the alerts.

Which didn't make it any less annoying, of course. More, actually, since the ducts in Goa'uld ships were not quite as roomy as those in Horde bases. And if she ever met the Jaffa tech who had installed the sensors on top of the grate so she had to lie on her back to spoof it, with dust and dried whatever falling down on her face every time she as much as touched the top of the duct… Her fur felt all sticky and dirty.

"Are we there yet?"

She rolled her eyes at O'Neill's comment. The joke hadn't been funny the first time he had made it, and it hadn't magically gotten funny after getting repeated three times. Maybe she shouldn't have told him that she could hear any Jaffa before they could hear Catra and her friends, so talking was fine if done in a low voice…

"Don't distract her!" Adora whispered behind her.

"I'm fine," Catra snapped as she cut the sensor's casing open.

"See? She's fine. How's the sensor, by the way?"

"She always says that!"

"I don't!" Catra hissed. "Now be quiet; we're close."

She connected the piece of metal she had pulled out of the last shredded grate to the sensor, then to the lower half of the grate. Good.

Then she unsheathed her claws and sliced the annoying obstacle into pieces. Some of them she stuffed into her belt for the next grate, the rest she pushed to the side before rolling on her belly. "Done!"

She started crawling ahead without waiting for an answer; sooner or later, the Jaffa would figure out where they were and do something about it. They needed to be at the bridge by then.

*****

Two more grates later, they were finally at their goal - well, almost. Through the grate, Catra could see the hallway leading to the bridge. And she could hear the… two? Yes, two… Jaffa who stood guard there. Probably in full armour, staff weapons ready and zats on their belts. At least, that was how the other guards they had seen had walked around.

Catra crawled back a bit, suppressing a hiss when her tail brushed over something sticky that smelt like old lubricant, around the

corner, where Adora and the others were waiting. “We’re at the right spot,” she whispered. “But we’re not close enough to hit the guards through the grate. And not far enough to quitely remove the grate without them noticing. Unless they’re asleep at their posts.”

“Such a dereliction of duty would be punished most harshly by any System Lord. And Sokar has a reputation of cruelty that stands out amongst his peers,” Teal’c said in a low voice.

“In other words, we can’t count on that,” O’Neill pointed out the obvious.

“So we have to be quick. Kick the grate out of the duct, then take out the guards before they can react and charge the bridge!” Adora said.

Catra knew what she meant. “Slice the grate to pieces, then do the same to the guards and the hatch leading to the bridge,” she corrected her lover. “Besides, I’m in front, so I have to be the first through the grate.”

“But…” Adora protested. “I could squirm past you.”

That would be… well, it had a certain appeal. And Catra knew from some experiments in Dryl’s castle that they were flexible enough to manage it. But they weren’t here for that. “I’ll go first - I’m faster and the smaller target.”

“But I can take a shot from them!” Adora retorted.

“Only if you transform into She-Ra. And good luck doing that inside here,” Catra pointed out.

“But…”

Catra didn’t have to see Adora’s face to know she was pouting. But Catra was right here - and they were running out of time. “Let’s go!” she hissed, then started crawling forward again.

She reached the grate and listened. Still two guards breathing. No one else. That was as good as it would get.

She unsheathed her claws, took a deep breath and sliced the grate with both hands. Before the first parts started to fall, she dug her feet's claws into the duct's metal and pushed herself forward, bursting through the remains of the grate - and into the hallway.

She curled up and flipped over, hitting the wall with her feet first - and jumped off again.

The Jaffa were quick - they fired at her before she touched the ground. But the plasma bolts missed, blasting the wall behind her as she rolled to the side, and the next volley hit the floor while she was already in the air, pouncing on them. She kicked the staff of the one on the left to the side, her feet's claws cutting through the top of it, and raked her hand's claws over and through the helmet and chestplate of the other.

He fell down, hands flailing as blood ran down his front, and she whirled towards the first guard, who was drawing his zat.

"For the Honour of Grayskull!" rang out from behind Catra.

The guard was good - Adora transforming into She-Ra didn't distract him at all. But he wasn't fast enough. She grabbed his right arm with her left, claws ripping into his muscles, before he could raise the weapon against her. He managed to land a glancing blow on her shoulder with his other arm, but she had taken worse in sparring. A swipe of her claws all but took his head off, helmet and all, and he collapsed in a pool of blood.

Catra turned to grin at Adora - and had to step to the side.

She-Ra was charging at the bulwark, sword out and glowing with power.

*****

Bruce Willis made it look so easy. Jack O'Neill clenched his teeth as he pushed himself out of the ventilation duct - it was just narrow enough so he couldn't crawl on all fours - and contorted himself so he wouldn't just fall down head-first to the floor below but land in a crouch, carbine ready.

Just in time for Adora to blow the hatch wide open with a swipe of her sword. Blow it to bits, actually - Jack flinched a little at the blast but didn't let that stop him from moving forward. While the smoke obscured the view - Catra charged through anyway, right behind Adora - Jack glanced behind him.

Teal'c slid out of the duct, grabbing the edge with one hand and swinging around to land on his feet, far more graceful than a man his size had any right to, Jack noted with a touch of jealousy.

Then Jack reached the smoke. Two steps into it, he dived to the right and rolled over his shoulder. He ended in a kneeling position, gun braced, and just had to lean a bit to the right to shoot a Jaffa coming around a console with a staff weapon ready. Jack hit him in the chest with a short burst, one bullet ricocheting off the armour - bad angle - but the others going right through it. The Jaffa stumbled, reaching out to the next console to steady himself, turning towards Jack.

Jack dropped him with another burst, to the head this time, and ran forward, bent over to present a smaller target. More staff weapons went off, and as he took a peek from behind the damaged console, he saw that half a dozen Jaffa were shooting at Adora, who had changed her sword into a shield to take the blasts. Two more were trying to flank her, but just as Jack started to aim at them, Catra dropped on them from the ceiling and started shredding them. Literally.

Jack switched targets and took out the closest threat to him with two rounds to their face and throat. He had to suppress the urge to lay down suppressive fire while Adora advanced - they couldn't risk damaging the bridge. Any more than it was already damaged, that was.

Where was Teal'c? Jack glanced to his left, at the door. No sign of his friend - and the smoke had almost cleared. Then he saw a flash through the door - a staff weapon firing.

Ah. Teal'c was holding off reinforcements.

Jack caught some movement to the side and whipped his gun around, putting a few rounds into a Jaffa crawling over the floor before the man could get to cover.

Another Jaffa flew over Jack's head, screaming until he hit the wall and dropped to the floor like a puppet with its strings cut. Jack put another two rounds into the collapsed figure just to be certain the Jaffa wouldn't get up behind him, then scanned the room again.

It was over. Adora stood there, still glowing, surrounded by five broken bodies. Dead and dying. Catra had finished her two earlier victims and gutted a third. She jerked, ears twitching. "Teal'c needs help."

"Shut down the hyperdrive! And the reactor! And seal or dump the ordnance!" Adora snapped as she whirled and raced back to the hallway, shield held up to catch more staff blasts.

Catra looked at her, then at the consoles - and then at Jack. "If I remember correctly, the main controls are smoking over there." She pointed at one of the damaged consoles. "There should be secondary controls, though. But I don't know where they are - or how to use them."

He winced and wished Carter were here - she would have already shut down the hyperdrive. "I think that wasn't covered in the general briefing. I'll make a note to rectify that oversight once we're back on Earth."

Catra snorted, then stepped forward, head cocking to the side. A moment later, she bent down and grabbed a Jaffa by the scruff of his neck, lifting the groaning man up one-handed. "Can you use

the secondary hyperdrive controls?" she asked, flashing the claws of her free hand in front of his face.

The Jaffa blinked, one eye already swelling shut, then coughed, blood running down his chin. "I-I'll never b-betray my g-god! Sokar!"

"Worth a try," Catra mumbled before dropping him on the ground again. She opened her mouth, then stopped, her ears twitching again. "Adora and Teal'c are done."

A few seconds later, Jack saw Adora enter the bridge. "We've blocked the passageway. It won't hold them for long, though," she said.

"We need the secondary controls - the primary are fried," Catra told her, nodding at the smoking console.

"You can access the secondary controls from any command console," Teal'c said, joining them. "But it usually requires codes only high-ranking Jaffa have."

And with Sokar being paranoid about security… Jack shook his head. He would really, really love to have Carter with them right now. Or Entrapta. Or Bow. But you fought your war with the army you had, not the army you wished you had. "So, I only see one way to stop this ship: We go and blow up the hyperdrive by hand." That would be dangerous and might cause the Jaffa to blow the ship up when they realised they couldn't stop them, but Jack didn't see any alternative. And then they would have to secure the ordnance magazines.

Catra and Adora nodded, looking grim.

"There is an alternative," Teal'c said. "Although it requires questionable and possibly dishonourable actions."

"Oh?" Jack cocked his head at his friend. "Hypothetically, what would we have to do?" He wasn't a stranger to torture, and he didn't think Catra would make a fuss, but...

Teal'c glanced at Adora, as Jack had expected. "It would require you to pose as a goddess and convert Sokar's faithful."

Jack blinked. He hadn't expected that.

*****

"Convert Sokar's faithful?" Adora gaped at Teal'c. He couldn't be serious! This had to be a joke - Teal'c had a very subtle sense of humour, a dry wit. This was… "I'm no goddess!" she blurted out.

"Yes, I know." Teal'c inclined his head. "Which is why this is a questionable and possibly dishonourable plan of action."

"Yeah, we call the snakes false gods for a reason." Jack nodded, but despite his words, he looked… not nearly as shocked as he should, in Adora's opinion.

And Catra… Adora glanced at her lover and winced. Judging by Catra's grin, she had no trouble with the plan at all. Not that there was a plan.

"Well, you managed to convert half the Horde fleet without even trying to - while trying to prevent them from converting…"

"That was different!" Adora protested. "Their situation was completely different! And it wasn't half the Horde fleet!"

"Details, details." Catra cocked her head at the groaning Jaffa on the ground. "But the Jaffa seem much more fanatical - and Adora hasn't killed Sokar yet."

"Sokar is well-known for his cruelty," Teal'c said. "Unlike his rival System Lords, he does not even attempt to inspire devotion - he rules through fear and terror." He looked at the wounded Jaffa. "Of all the false gods' followers, his are potentially the most vulnerable to conversion."

Oh. Adora blinked again. That was what this was about - it wasn't just about stopping the Ha'ak. It was about saving the Jaffa from

dying for their masters.

Which, she realised, she probably should start doing right away, seeing as a number of them were dying in front of her. You couldn't convert - turn, she corrected herself, turn - the dead. And they were running out of time - Catra was looking towards the bulwark they had closed and barricaded, her ears twitching. That meant that the Jaffa were attacking it, trying to break through.

She looked around. Four Jaffa had survived the battle on the bridge. Three of them were conscious but they didn't look good. If she healed them, it might kill the symbiont, dooming them… On the other hand, they might die without help anyway, and if they died, the symbiont would die as well… And they were prisoners - she couldn't just let them die.

Adora took a deep breath and pointed her sword at the closest. He tensed, one hand clutching his side - his legs were mangled from getting thrown at the closest console - but he was staring at her defiantly. He must be expecting death.

She smiled at him as gently as she could and focused on her power. A moment later, her sword started to glow, and magic shot out of it, engulfing the Jaffa. She heard him gasp as she healed him, then turned to heal the others on the floor.

A few seconds later, all four were whole. One was patting himself down as if he couldn't believe it - he had been unconscious, Adora remembered. But the other three were still staring at her.

"I am She-Ra," she told them. "Princess of Power. I am not a Goa'uld. I fight the false gods who use lies and cruelty to rule and oppress others."

"We will never betray our god Sokar!" the first Jaffa she had healed yelled - and lunged, reaching for a staff weapon near him. Before Adora could react, Catra hit him with her shock rod, and he collapsed.

"What a pain," Adora's lover commented with a sigh.

Jack snorted at that, of course, as he stunned the Jaffa with his zat before he could recover.

Adora wanted to sigh as well as she turned to address the remaining three, who hadn't moved. That was an encouraging sign, wasn't it? "I have healed you because you don't deserve to die for being lied to, for being manipulated - and for being betrayed."

She saw the Jaffa glance at the corpses surrounding them and suppressed a wince. But none of them asked why Adora and her friends had killed the others. They would be used to such cruelty, Adora reminded herself, based on what they knew about Sokar.

"Sokar is our god," another said as Jack, Teal'c and Catra tied them up.

Adora shook her head. "He is a false god. He uses deceit and trickery to fool you. He…"

"They're about to break through!" Catra interrupted her.

Adora felt relieved as she turned to face the hallway. Trying to turn people from following the Goa'uld was hard. Fighting them was easy.

"W… Will you kill them?"

Adora froze for a fraction of a second, then glanced over her shoulder at the Jaffa who had spoken. The other two were glaring at him, but he looked at her with a weird expression.

"I will do my best not to kill them," Adora told him.

She heard the door break in the hallway and charged forward, changing her sword into a shield again as the first Jaffa entered the hallway. He fired at her with his staff weapon, but she easily caught the bolt on her shield - and two more, one from him and one from the Jaffa behind him, before she slammed into him.

He was thrown into the broken bulwark, hard enough to break bones, but he would live. Or so she hoped as she whirled to face the next enemies. A volley of staff blasts and zat shots splashed against her shield. Snarling, she swung it around, knocking half a dozen Jaffa off their feet.

A few quick steps carried her into the midst of their formation. She kicked one, breaking his weapons and his arm, hit another with her free hand, knocking him out, then used her shield to deflect more shots.

She heard Catra's shock rod go off behind her - someone must have been still a threat - as she widened her shield with a thought, matching the hallway's width, then charged forward, pushing the remaining Jaffa, twenty at least, into each other and back against the wall, barely managing to stop herself from crushing the lot of them.

Yes, that was much easier than trying to turn them.

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Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter stared at the clock on her screen. "ETA thirty seconds." She checked the data from the spy drones. The enemy ships were moving according to the expected patterns.

If everything went according to plan, Priest's task force would be dropping out of hyperspace right on top of the enemy fleet. That was cutting it a bit too close for Sam's taste, but it wasn't her plan. Priest had insisted on attacking the fleet in order to secure the information they needed, and while Priest wasn't officially in charge of the mission even with Adora missing, Sam knew better than to try to give an order that would be refused.

And he was a veteran of such engagements - Sam had never taken part in a fleet action. But still… they were trusting her - and Entrapta's - data. The clones had calculated their exit vectors based on Sam and Entrapta's estimates of the enemy fleet's

movements. If they had made a mistake… The clones knew the risk, but Sam still held her breath as the seconds ticked down, watching for the slightest deviation from the expected patterns. At least for the capital ships - the Death Gliders were moving almost randomly, and the Tel'taks had slightly erratic patterns.

"They've done this before," Bow said. "They have wiped out Apophis's forces. They know their enemy."

Bow was right - but he also sounded as if he was trying to reassure himself. If the Colonel were here, he'd make a joke to break the tension. And a point to show how relaxed he was.

But he wasn't here.

"Ten seconds!" Entrapta announced.

Nine… eight… seven…

"Jamming field active!" It wouldn't stop the fleet's FTL comms forever, but long enough for this battle.

Sam looked at the sensor readings again. Oh, no!

"Uh-oh! Deviation!" Entrapta had noticed it as well.

"What?" Bow craned his neck to look at their screen.

But it was too late. The task force dropped out of hyperspace to rake the enemy fleet at point-blank range while the Jaffa were still shocked.

And one frigate dropped right into the path of an Al'kesh which had changed course a moment ago. Far too close for either ship to react and avoid the collision. The spy drone network and the shuttle's sensors showed every detail.

The frigate's batteries fired. They shattered the Al'kesh's shields but couldn't stop it. And neither could the frigate's shields. Sam clenched her teeth as the shields flared, then died, and the

Al'kesh, already wrecked, trailing parts and leaking atmosphere, rammed into the frigate's bow.

Not even a Horde frigate could take that kind of impact. The bow armour buckled for a second, like a crash test in slow motion, then shattered - and the bow crumpled, then was crushed as the main body of the frigate ploughed through the remains of the Al'kesh.

For a fraction of a second, Sam had hope that the frigate, though irreparably wrecked, had survived, but then an explosion engulfed both wrecks, quickly followed by secondary explosions that ripped the frigate's wreck apart.

Sam closed her eyes for a second and drew a hissing breath. That was… It wasn't her fault. She hadn't wanted this attack. She had warned Priest. The clones knew the risks.

But she still felt guilty.

"Oh. The Al'kesh must have been carrying a full load of bombs," Entrapta said. "I can't tell if they were deliberately detonated or blew up from the impact. Usually, they wouldn't be armed unless they were expecting combat, but since they were looking for us…"

"...they might have had their bombs ready to be launched," Sam finished for her friend. Which would have been stupid, of course - bombs were near-useless in combat outside a planet's atmosphere. But if that was standard procedure, the Jaffa would have armed the bombs.

It didn't matter anyway. Sam checked the rest of the battle. If you could call it a battle. The task force had double the numbers of the enemy fleet - and a Horde frigate had more firepower than a Ha'tak. The Al'keshs were wiped out in no time even with half the force focusing on the Ha'taks. The Tel'taks were not faring any better. A handful tried to escape using their stealth system, but with the spy drones' sensor network linked to Priest's task force,

that merely meant that they were destroyed without shooting back.

One Ha'tak accelerated, trying to enter hyperspace. But it was too late - the ship ran into a squadron of frigates and all but disintegrated under their fire.

Sam pressed her lips together so she wouldn't call Priest to remind him that they needed prisoners to find the missing team. The clone commander was aware of that - and of the fact that they had to ensure that no enemy ship escaped to report to Sokar.

And, seeing as a number of Ha'taks were drifting dead in space but hadn't blown up, it looked like they would get their prisoners.

Sam could only hope that it would be enough to narrow down the missing Ha'tak's destination; the data they had so far only netted them a general direction.

And that wasn't enough to find their missing friends.

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Scouting Part 3

Hyperspace, Near Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra clenched her teeth. Adora had the situation under control - in the hallway, there was no way even an entire army of Jaffa could get past her. But that only secured the bridge. "We need to get to the hyperdrive. And the ordnance magazines. Before the Jaffa in command figures out that they can't beat us."

"Yep," O'Neill agreed. "Our princess can't be in two places at once - much less three." He looked at Teal'c. "So… we've got two locations to secure. And a bridge to guard."

"I'll take the ordnance magazines," Catra announced. O'Neill opened his mouth, presumably to protest, and she flashed her teeth and added: "I can fight perfectly fine without any risk of accidentally shooting the Naquadah-enhanced bombs or whatever they have there."

He blinked, then pouted. "Good point."

"I will go to the hyperdrive," Teal'c said. "I should be able to disable it without significantly damaging it."

"Well, I think Adora can handle the bridge here just fine," O'Neill said.

"She's busy fighting. Someone has to guard the bridge," Catra objected. "And we need someone in reserve if something else goes wrong." That was basic officer training.

O'Neill narrowed his eyes at her. "You know, it should be me telling you to stay back as a reserve."

"Good luck with that." She snorted and turned towards the ventilation duct. "I'll take the ducts - Adora should make the perfect distraction." She easily jumped up to the opening and dug

her claws into the metal to pull herself into the ducts. As she started to crawl towards where the magazines should be, she heard O'Neill complain about no one listening to him any more and chuckled. The guy needed to accept that he wasn't the only one allowed to risk his life. Or have fun.

And they did need someone held back in reserve. Adora was great, but she wasn't perfect. And sometimes, she was a bit too naive. O'Neill was the best choice to handle her. Except., of course, for Catra, but she was the best choice to secure the magazines.

She gritted her teeth as she speed-crawled through the dirty ducts, and her tail once again dragged through something slimy. Even with the suit on… she'd spend an hour in the bath after this, just so she could feel clean again. She should put her helmet on, but… it limited her vision and hearing. And her sense of smell. And that could be fatal here. A bit of dirt was a small price to pay. Or should be.

So she pressed her lips together and pushed on until she reached the shaft that should lead down to the floor with the magazines. The Goa'uld had them in the centre of the ship - well-protected. Using her claws made descending easy - if a bit hard on her ears. But a few seconds later, she was on the right floor. Just a bit more crawling through stinky ducts.

Finally, she reached the right… area. Whatever. She sneaked up on the grate covering the opening and tried to look into the hallway. Nothing. No guards at the magazine? That didn't feel right. But she couldn't hear or smell anyone, either.

Well, she had an objective to secure. If the enemy had made a mistake, she wouldn't complain.

She shredded the grate and dropped into the hallway, quickly checking left and right. Still nothing. Ah, well.

A moment later, she was at the hatch leading to the magazines. A few swipes of her claws made short work of the metal on one side. Hah! O'Neill would have had to blow it open, and you didn't do that with magazines! She kicked the remains of the door, and it swung open.

And she cursed. This was a lot of heavy ordnance. Bombs. Missiles. No personal arms, though - those would be somewhere else. But the weapon lockers wouldn't have ordnance able to destroy the ship. Or so she hoped.

On a Horde surface ship, she would flood the magazines to render them safe. But this wouldn't work here, for a lot of reasons. And she couldn't defuse so many bombs and warheads, anyway.

That left making sure no one could get to them. Fortunately, she came prepared for that.

She grinned as she reached into her belt pocket and pulled out the charges. They weren't Horde incendiary packs, but Earth 'thermite' would work well enough.

A minute later, she had the entire hallway wired - around piled-up metal shredded from the next hallways. Ready to melt and block access. Now she just had to…

The sound of a hatch opening made her whirl around. Jaffa! That meant she couldn't set a timer and escape through the ducts - they might defuse it.

Baring her teeth, she set the timer for one minute and charged towards the enemy.

*****

Jack O'Neill wasn't supposed to stay back while his team risked their lives. Good officers led from the front. At least when in charge of small units, he amended his thoughts. But you couldn't really get much smaller than a team of four.

And yet, from a purely military perspective, it made sense. Somewhat. Adora was a one-woman army and could handle the Jaffa attacking them, but they had to secure the magazines and take out the hyperdrive, and fast. And someone had to guard the bridge and be held in reserve if something else went wrong on this mission. Teal'c knew this class of ship best and was familiar with Goa'uld technology, so he was the logical choice to go and sabotage the hyperdrive. And Catra was better in close combat than Jack - though her claws gave her an unfair advantage. Add her enhanced senses, and she really was a female version of Wolverine, right down to the attitude and bloody past. Jack wouldn't say that she was the better soldier, though - he had a bag of tricks and a few decades of experience on her. Still, she probably was the better choice to go and secure the ship's magazines.

But Jack still wasn't happy staying back. It felt wrong. He couldn't even lead from here - everyone knew what they were doing, and trying to micromanage others was a terrible idea to start with anyway. At least if you had a competent team. And if you didn't have a competent team, that was on you as the leader.

He looked around the bridge. No attempt to break through the walls. No secret passage opening. And the consoles were still broken - not that he could fix that, anyway. He was good at destroying stuff. Carter was the one you wanted when it came to fixing things. He checked the bound and stunned prisoners for the third time in five minutes. They were still out. And not dying.

Wait. He cocked his head and shifted his carbine a bit. The sounds of battle had stopped. Jack tapped his mic. "Adora?"

"Just a second!" her voice sounded over the comms. *"Have to… close this… door…"*

She was probably wrenching it shut, Jack imagined.

"Done! That should hold them - once they return."

If they returned. Judging by what he had heard, and what he had glimpsed before returning to the bridge, Adora had gone through the Jaffa like a hot knife through butter. Or more like a bowling ball through a set of pins. On a greased floor.

And there she was - looking none the worse for wear, despite having just flattened dozens of Jaffa. Maybe even more of them. Although… he frowned. She looked almost… embarrassed?

"Uh, Jack? I need some help."

"Yes?"

"I've knocked out most of the Jaffa, after healing the worst, but… we need a room to put the prisoners into." She smiled weakly. "And I kind of broke the locks of the only room big enough to hold them."

Oh, hell! "I don't think we have enough strips to tie them up," Jack said. Not that it would do any good - you could guard four bound prisoners by yourself. You couldn't really guard a few dozen bound prisoners.

And they couldn't just shoot the bastards, either. "I guess we better stun them all." That would buy them some time to find a better solution. And speaking of buying time… Jack tapped his mic again. "Status?"

"I'm about to engage the guards at the objective," Teal'c reported, as calmly as if he was talking about taking a stroll to the mess hall.

Good. Jack nodded even though his friend couldn't see it. He'd bet on Teal'c against any other Jaffa. Or a couple of them. He trusted him to win this.

"I'm fine."

Catra's report, on the other hand, was a bit off. And Jack wasn't the only one to notice.

"Catra! What's happened?" Adora asked.

"I've got the hallway to the magazines melting down," Catra replied. *"I just need to… deal with some guards."*

"You're not fine!" Adora protested. She looked at Jack. "I know her! She's in trouble!"

He agreed - Catra sounded tense, and just a bit more stressed than she usually did.

"I'm fine. I've been through worse. And those guards can't stop me!"

Her ears were working fine, at least. And she wasn't dead. And, the part of Jack that he often hated, added, she had achieved her objective.

Adora bit her lower lip. "I can make my way to you - we're done here."

"I can handle this!" Catra snapped. *"You do your task! I do mine!"*

"But…"

Adora was cut off by the whole ship suddenly lurching - and a new alert going off on the bridge. That meant…

"I have successfully disabled the hyperdrive," Teal'c confirmed Jack's thoughts. *"But I was detected by reinforcements."*

Jack could hear the sound of staff weapons blasting away in the background. He looked at Adora.

She stared back at him. "I can reach either of them faster than you can."

And safer. But she didn't have to say that. Jack sighed and drew his zat. "I'll stun the prisoners."

*****

Catra was in danger! Adora knew she shouldn't have let her lover go off alone - Catra was tough, and strong, and smart, but she wasn't as tough as She-Ra - she couldn't shrug off staff blasts! And in the narrow hallways of the Ha'tak, she couldn't dodge as well as she usually could. If there were enough Jaffa massed to shoot at her…

Adora clenched her teeth as she charged down a corridor, towards the door she had just blocked. She gripped the edge of the door and pulled, grunting as she ripped it open.

A staff blast hit her in the head and another in the shoulder before she brought her shield up and caught three more blasts on it. Oh, for… "I've got no time for this!" she yelled and charged ahead. More staff blasts peppered her shield and the hallway around her. One blew a hole in the floor, and she almost stumbled when her foot was caught in it, but she pulled her leg free and kept going.

The Jaffa were stacked three rows deep, three wide - the first row kneeling, the other two standing, all firing. They tried to blow the floor away, but Adora jumped - and smashed her shield into them, shattering their formation. And probably their bones, but right now, she didn't care. Catra needed her.

Two Jaffa were still fighting, one on the ground, pointing a zat at her, the other even getting up and raising his staff weapon. She flung her arm out and knocked the second into the wall while staring at the first. He fired at her - once, twice, three times. Four times. Then he stopped, mouth falling open.

Adora bared her teeth at him before knocking him out.

"Catra! I'm coming!" she yelled into her comm.

"I'm fine!" came the answer. *"Secure the bridge!"*

She wasn't fine - Adora could tell. But she had a point about the bridge.

Adora turned around and jumped over the hole in the floor, then sped to the wrecked door. It took more effort to wrench it closed - and warp it so the Jaffa couldn't easily pull it open - but that should keep Jack safe. Safe-ish. Long enough for Adora to fetch Catra and return, at least. And get Teal'c.

"Teal'c, status?"

That was Jack.

"I am changing position to avoid becoming pinned down, O'Neill."

So, Teal'C was also in a bind. Catra first, then Teal'C. "I'm coming!"

"No… Don't!"

Adora scoffed and started running - and jumping - again. Although… if she had to go through Jaffa at every intersection… She stopped, then frowned as she recalled the deck plans of a Ha'tak.

The magazines were below the bridge. Quite a bit below, but… She concentrated on her sword, returning it to its original form. Then she stabbed it into the floor and cut a wide circle around herself.

A second later, she dropped down, jumping off before her slice hit the floor with a loud crash. The Jaffa would hear that, but she was already cutting the next hole. By the time she cut the fourth, she caught a glimpse of charging Jaffa before she dropped out of sight.

She moved a step back, swatted the two Jaffa jumping after her out of the air, and cut another hole into the floor.

This time, the crash wasn't quite as loud, but she dropped right in front of another group of Jaffa. She struck them down with her sword-turned-shield. Then she noticed that this had just been half

a group - she had dropped part of the ceiling on top of the other half, crushing them into a paste.

Grimacing, she cut the next hole into smaller pieces. That one should lead her to the magazine floor. A moment later, she was on the right floor. Now, where was Catra? With all the alerts blaring, she couldn't hear any noise from fighting. But she could ask. "Catra, where are you?"

"I am fine!"

"I am on the same floor now!" Adora snapped. "Tell me where you are!"

"I am headed upstairs. Just need to… deal with some annoying pests."

That meant… Adora turned and sprinted left. The magazines were in the other direction, but the stairs were this way. A few hallways and turns, as well as one hapless group of Jaffa, later, she saw flashes in the distance - staff blasts! Catra!

She pushed herself to run even faster, her shield changing into a sword, and turned the corner, blade rising…

"Hey, Adora!" Catra smirked at her.

"Catra!" Adora could see about a dozen Jaffa on the floor - Catra was standing on one who was missing his head.

"I told you I was fine!"

But she wasn't fine! "You're hurt!" Adora gasped. Catra's suit was damaged on her side! And scorched on her thigh!

"It's just a scratch. I can still…"

Adora tuned her out and pointed her sword at her. Her lover was hurt, and she would heal her.

“Look, I…”

Adora healed her. Then she pulled her into a hug. Catra kept protesting, of course, but that didn’t matter. She was safe and whole again.

Now they just had to fight their way to Teal’c and return to the bridge.

*****

Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“The boarding team has breached the hull.”

Samantha Carter didn’t need the report - she could see that herself on her screen; she had a direct feed from the bots assaulting the crippled Ha’tak. She had used remote controls to hack the airlock controls - and this time, she had made sure that any overrides were disabled, even if that took a bot to physically burn out a circuit or connector. But it had taken longer than if she had been present. Too long when every minute counted. She knew there was a risk that the Jaffa might self-destruct, but in this case…

“Oh, look at them!” Entrapta commented. “The Jaffa are ready for them!”

Sam pressed her lips together. Indeed, and it was her fault. If she had been faster, then the bots would have still had the element of surprise. As it was, it looked like the opening of Star Wars as the white bots poured through the narrow hallway into a hail of staff blasts, firing their own blasters even as they dropped one after another.

But, like stormtroopers, they just kept coming, climbing over the fallen - their own and the Jaffa’s. The feed on the screen switched three times as bot after bot was destroyed before the Jaffa at the airlock were falling back - and then once more when the next bot ran into an ambush further into the ship.

"Second shuttle docking."

Samantha quickly hit a few keys on her laptop and collected the data from the assault. The bots had taken six times the casualties of the Jaffa in the engagement. Sure, the defenders had been prepared, and conventional wisdom meant an attacker needed three times the troops of a defender, but she still didn't like those odds. "The bots need better armour and shields," she muttered as she watched the attacking force hit the next choke point.

"Yeah," Bow agreed. "But they're still pretty tough - they gave us a hard time when Prime invaded Etheria. Those Jaffa are good."

When they weren't facing princesses. Or SG-1, Sam added in her mind. "We can't underestimate them."

"But we can build better bots! Although improving every bot would take a long time," Entrapta said. "Maybe some assault bots with better shields? Like Emily? Well, she's too large to fit into those hallways, so not exactly like Emily, just tough enough to withstand the Jaffa's blasters long enough to take them out."

Spearheading units. That sounded like a good idea, but Sam wanted to run it by the Colonel and Teal'c. She clenched her teeth. She would do it. When they were back. When, not if, she reminded herself. They would return safely. They had to.

"Yes," Glimmer chimed in. "And we should have special assault shuttles that can lock onto a ship's hull and then breach it. That way, we could bypass chokepoints and hit a target with multiple attacks."

Entrapta nodded. "Oh, yes! We thought about such a system, but they weren't compatible with the stealth system - well, they would have required a much bigger hull, which would have meant the stealth system would have to be bigger and need more power as well, and that meant an even bigger ship, which would make it harder for the stealth system to compensate for the delay from the light being bent around it, which means even more power,

and more computing power, would be needed, and that would require better shielding, and… well, there's a point where you can't really hide your emissions any more because you're just putting out too much power. But! A dedicated space assault shuttle should be possible!"

"If we have the time to design it," Sam said. "We have a lot of urgent projects."

On the screen, the bots had overcome the ambushing force and were now spreading out to secure the bridge and the magazines. And a third shuttle was delivering more bots.

She brought up the Ha'tak's deck plans, highlighting the routes to the bridge - the hyperdrive and engines had already been taken out by naval fire during the attack.

"Yeah, a second attack would have forced them to split their soldiers," Glimmer commented. "We probably would have taken fewer casualties that way - leverage our numbers."

"Well, we can repair the bots," Entrapta pointed out. "They can't repair the Jaffa. Not in those numbers, at least."

From anyone else, that would have been a very cynical statement. But Entrapta didn't mean it like that - she merely pointed out the obvious. Of coure, Goa'uld could use sarcophaguses, but the odds of those making a difference in a war were very, very low - if they were used at all on Jaffa. "Repairs cost time and other resources," Sam said. "But we can spare those." Training a Jaffa took far longer than building a bot took. But between all the System Lords, there were many, many Jaffa. Even with more automated factories, it would take a long time, and huge casualties, until the numerical advantage would shift to the Alliance.

"The assault force is about to reach the bridge."

Sam could see that - she recognised the armoured doors leading to the bridge on the screen now. And the defenders who had

made their stand outside the bridge were already dead. Soon they would have the bridge under control, and then there was only…

The feed cut off. Sam frowned. Another ambush? And why didn't it switch…? She looked at her laptop and mentally cursed.

"The Ha'tak has blown up."

The screen showed an explosion. Sam had the record go back to a moment before the explosion. There. The Ha'tak blew up from the inside. In slow motion, she could see the shockwave ripping the ship apart before it vanished. And the origin of the explosion… She checked the readings from the spy bots against the deck plans. As she expected: the magazines.

"They blew themselves up by detonating their own ordnance," Sam said. "The assault force didn't manage to secure the magazines in time."

*****

Unknown Location, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra was fine! And had been fine. It had just been a scratch. And a bit of bleeding where Entrapta's suit hadn't managed to completely deflect a blast. And a lot of pain in her thigh from another glancing blow. But she had had worse! And she had still kicked ass! Adora had no reason to baby her like this!

Even if it was a little bit flattering to see such a reaction from her lover. And heartwarming - well, something-warming, at least.

But still tactically unsound. Catra had dealt with the enemies attacking her, and she had been about to disappear into the ventilation ducts again. Once she found them.

"Should have gone to Teal'c first," she muttered as she ran behind Adora down another hallway.

"He isn't wounded!"

“He wasn’t,” Catra corrected her. “He might be wounded now.”

“*He* would have told us if he was,” Adora shot back.

Catra clenched her teeth. That was a low blow!

They turned a corner and ran straight at - into - a group of Jaffa. Adora’s shield took the staff blasts they managed to get off and then barrelled through them. Catra quickly took out the two Jaffa that were not down from getting smashed into the walls - or the ceiling. A kick knocked one out, and a swipe of her claw disarmed the other. Not quite literally.

“It only counts if it’s serious!” she said as they ran up some emergency stairs.

“If it’s bleeding, it’s serious!”

“Not if it’s just a scratch!”

“It wasn’t!”

“It was!” Catra scoffed - Adora had no way to prove it had been worse than that! “Now drop it - we’re on the right deck!”

“What? I should drop it?”

Catra tapped her communicator as she raced past Adora, down the hallway from which she heard fighting. “Teal’c? We’re on the hyperdrive deck. We’re almost with you. Coming from the emergency staircase.”

“Noted.”

As expected, Adora pushed herself and passed Catra right before they reached the intersection where Teal’c was…

…barricaded inside a shot-up alcove, with half a dozen corpses lining the hallway between him and the enemy.

Adora didn’t bother stopping and just continued to run straight at the Jaffa - more than half a dozen - trying to suppress Teal’c for another push. They switched targets at once, but once again, her sword-turned-shield took the blows without a problem.

Catra stopped next to Teal’c and crouched down. “Are you hurt? If yes, is it serious?”

“It is not serious,” he replied as she took a step out of the alcove, staff aimed forward.

“Don’t bother wasting ammo. Adora needs to work off some tension,” Catra told him as nonchalantly as she could.

“I see.” Teal’c slowly nodded - and didn’t even react when a screaming Jaffa flew past them to smash into the wall behind them at an angle that had him ricochet and hit the ceiling before landing on the floor.

“Lots of tension,” Catra added.

“Indeed.”

But half a dozen Jaffa didn’t last long against one She-Ra, and Adora quickly rejoined them. “Teal’c! Are you hurt?”

“Not seriously,” Catra replied for him. She used her communicator again. “Jack? We’ve got Teal’c. How are things with you?”

“Great! And just peachy so far. Not sure how much longer, though.”

Of course, her idiot lover had to heal Teal’c anyway. And then the wounded Jaffa, so they had to spend a minute stunning everyone with their own zats. Well, Teal’c did that - when one shot stunned and two killed, you didn’t want two shooters who might mix up who got whom.

And it wouldn’t do to accidentally kill a Jaffa whom Adora had gone to such lengths to keep alive. Even though Catra was rather

sceptical about Adora's chance to actually turn some of them away from Sokar. Then again, if anyone could do it, it was Adora - and she hadn't really had the necessary time to give it a good try. But that could wait. Other things couldn't. "Alright. Let's go back to Jack before the Jaffa manage to break through to the bridge," she said.

"Indeed. I think we should forego stealth and make haste."

"Yes." Adora, predictably, agreed with the plan. She raised her shield and started running towards the central stairway.

Cara half-expected Teal'c to suggest a less obvious route - the Jaffa would be using the stairway as well - but he didn't seem to be bothered at all. Not that it was easy to tell, of course. Not with him. Still, she had the suspicion that he liked this.

Then she couldn't dwell on it any more since they hit the first choke point between them and the central stairway, and even with Adora taking the brunt of the enemies' attention and fire, Catra had to focus on dodging and taking cover - and taking out survivors, together with Teal'c.

And the Jaffa kept coming. Even Adora had to slow down - though that might mostly be because she tried not to kill them. Catra wanted to berate her for it, but… The Jaffa were similar to Horde soldiers. Raised to blindly follow their leader. She could understand that.

Of course, they were trying their best to kill Catra and her friends, so that didn't mean Catra would be sentimental about killing the back before they succeeded. She wasn't Adora, after all.

Baring her teeth, she cut down a Jaffa with a mangled arm who still tried to fire his staff at Teal'c's back.

Yeah, raised from birth, indoctrinated and lied to the Jaffa might be, but Catra's friends still came first for her.

*****

Teal’c was safe. Jack O’Neill briefly sighed with relief. His friend was tough, but he wasn’t a magical princess or a catwoman version of Wolverine. And he was fighting other Jaffa with the same weapons. But he was safe now - and he had accomplished his mission; they had dropped out of hyperspace. With the magazines secure, the hyperdrive disabled and the bridge under their control, the Ha’tak wouldn’t be going anywhere.

Of course, the team’s situation wasn’t anywhere close to alright. They were still just four people facing hundreds of enemies, trapped in the middle of space - probably, the odds of them dropping out in an inhabited system were low. Carter would say astronomically low, but with the way things had been going, Jack wouldn’t be shocked if they had managed to end up right on top of another snake’s home system. Pissed, of course, but not shocked.

But they were better off than they had been - Jack was dead certain that wherever they had been going wouldn’t have been a friendly place. Taking control of a Ha’tak didn’t do you any good if the enemy just shot it to pieces, and while Adora might survive that - might; Jack was pretty sure she wasn’t some real-life version of Supergirl - Jack had no illusions that he would.

So, he just had to trust that Carter and the others would do their science-magic and find them. Before anyone else did. And he did. Trust, that was. And yet… If only Carter were with them! Teal’c had grown up with all the Goa’uld technology, and that was a godsend, but he didn’t quite understand it as Carter did.

But enough pointless wishing. Jack had a bridge and a few dozen prisoners to guard. And a few dozen or more Jaffa to keep from breaking through the doors Adora had jammed to take the bridge back. Which was a tall order for a lone guy without magic powers.

But Jack only had to hold out until the rest arrived. And he had experience with such situations. Granted, in Iraq, it hadn’t worked out as well as he would have liked, but…

He heard a banging noise from the blocked door and clenched his teeth. “Looks like we’re going to have visitors…”

He moved back to the corner of the next intersection and crouched down against the wall, taking up a firing position, before tapping his mic. “Call out when you’re coming - I’m about to have company here and don’t want to shoot you by mistake.”

“What? Oh, no! We’re coming. Hurry up!” Adora gasped over the radio.

Another banging noise. The door shook a bit - unless that was his imagination. No, it wasn’t - he could see it shift now. Were they literally breaking it down?

A blast that shredded the door and forced him to duck around the corner answered that. He moved forward again at once, just in time to catch the first Jaffa through the smoking hole with a burst to the chest.

The tough bastard stumbled but didn’t go down, even firing his staff weapon - although he hit the ceiling.

Jack shot him again, and the Jaffa fell over, but more were already coming out of the smoke. Jack put a few bullets into the first, but a near-miss sprayed wall fragments all over his position, and he had to duck back again.

More staff blasts hit the corner, damaging it further, and others hit the wall on the other side. Good suppressive fire, Jack had to admit. Sokar trained his Jaffa well.

But that also meant they were kind of predictable. Jack counted to five - with all the shooting, he wouldn’t be able to hear them charge up - and then pushed the button on his remote detonator.

The C-4 going off in the hallway around the corner almost deafened him, and the pressure wave was a bit harder than he had expected, but a quick glance around the corner confirmed

that his improvised claymore had cut the Jaffa attacking the bridge to bits. Bloody bits.

He shot at one guy in the back who was still moving, then had to fall back when the next wave arrived and started suppressing his corner again.

He stopped at the entrance to the bridge - in hindsight, destroying that door had been a bit hasty - and aimed his carbine down the hallway. Hopefully, the Jaffa would expect another mine and proceed more carefully.

Judging by the sudden yelling, they were doing the opposite.

"Getting a bit crowded here," he muttered into his mic.

"We're coming!"

This time, he waited with detonating the next mine until the first Jaffa turned the corner. The explosion threw them around, and Jack finished the three staggering Jaffa with a few quick bursts. "There's more where that came from!" he yelled, wishing it were true. At least, he consoled himself as he heard more yelling, trying to fake them out with a decoy bomb to slow them down, preferably in my line of fire, would have been a waste of time.

But here they came again! Packed tightly and several rows deep, as if they were reenacting Gettysburg, they charged. Jack shot the first row with a few bursts, then the next as they jumped and climbed over the fallen and tried to ignore the staff blasts hitting close to him.

Then his eyes widened as one Jaffa wound his arm up - grenade!

Jack switched to full auto and emptied his magazine into the man, but all he managed was to spoil the aim - instead of landing inside the bridge, the grenade landed in the middle of the hallway.

Jack dove to the side, behind a console, a moment before it got off, then rolled over and aimed at the entrance again while he

changed magazines. They were yelling again - angry. And he was out of tricks. And almost out of ammo.

Wait - those yells were different.

"We're coming! We're almost at the bridge!"

Ah. Jack grinned as he shot a Jaffa who was as much charging as fleeing through the door, then the next one who was actually shooting backwards.

The cavalry had arrived in time.

*****

A Jaffa was trying to hit her with his staff. Adora ducked under the swing, swept her leg around and sent the man somersaulting through the air. He managed to land on his side, not on his head, but a strike with the flat side of her sword dropped him for good. That left…

..none? She blinked. The entrance to the bridge was clear, she could see Jack standing up behind a console to the side, Teal'c was guarding their rear, and Catra was… "Catra!" Adora snapped. "Don't maim the prisoners!"

"He was still fighting," her lover retorted. "And I barely scratched him."

"If he's still fighting, then he's not a prisoner," Jack commented as he joined them. "Thanks for the help. That was getting a bit dicey."

"It's what Adora does," Catra said with a snort. "Whether or not you need the help."

Adora didn't pout. But she frowned. Yes, she would help people - it was the right thing to do. Whether or not they wanted help didn't matter - Catra was the best example that often, people didn't know or wanted to accept that they needed help.

“So, block the hallway again?” Catra asked, pointing her head towards the bulwark they had come through.

“It would be prudent,” Teal’c said, still watching the hallway. “Although I think between the engagements we fought so far, the main part of the crew has been dealt with.”

Really? But a Ha’tak had… Adora ran a quick calculation in her head. Oh. It might actually fit.

“Maybe they’ve also realised that they can’t beat us no matter how many of them attack us,” Catra said.

“I don’t know about that.” Jack shrugged. “They’re a stubborn lot. Death before dishonour and all that.”

“They have been taught that death is preferable to failing,” Teal’c added. “In light of Sokar’s reputation, they might also falsely believe that their death would expunge their failure and grant them some leniency in the afterlife.”

“I’ve got a feeling that if dear Sokar could punish his followers in the afterlife, they would be out of luck no matter what,” Jack said. “Anyway! We need to find out where we are and how to contact our friends so they can come and fetch us - and our prize.”

“Prize?” Adora asked. “Oh, you mean the ship. I thought you stopped that practice on Earth.” She frowned. “I actually think that was explicitly left out in the Alliance treaty - I remember Mermista saying she didn’t want to risk the Alliance going bankrupt by paying for prizes.” Apparently, that had once almost happened to Salineas during a war with the Kingdom of Snows when their fleet had managed to capture an entire flotilla of enemy ships.

“It was a figure of speech. We don’t exactly pay people for taking prizes any more. Pity - I could’ve retired with my take from this,” Jack said with a grin.

Catra snorted. “As if you’d retire in the middle of the war.” She shrugged. “So… are the comms still working? We should still be in range of some of our forces.”

Adora knew she meant the spy bot network but wouldn’t mention that where the prisoners could overhear them.

“I will check the systems,” Teal’c said. “You can guard the bridge and see to the wounded.”

Right! Adora hefted her sword. She had to heal the prisoners before they died.

“My ears are ringing, but otherwise, I’m fine,” Jack said.

And her friends, of course! She pointed her sword at Jack and healed him, then started on the downed Jaffa around her once Jack was ready to stun them with his zat. And Catra had taken their weapons, of course.

This could take a while, she realised. And, worse, in the rush to save her friends, she had left a lot of wounded strewn along the route she had taken.

“We have to hurry!” Adora said, starting to heal the prisoners. “We can’t let them die!”

“Yeah, I mean, it’s not as if they have been trying to kill us all…” Jack muttered as he stunned the next Jaffa she had healed.

“They are our prisoners - we are responsible for them!” Adora told him with a frown. That was the same on Etheria and on Earth.

And not all of them looked like they were still trying to kill them, she noticed as she healed the next batch of wounded Jaffa. Some of them seemed grateful for the healing, the way they looked at her. In fact, their expressions seemed a bit familiar…

The next one she healed muttered something she didn’t quite catch. ‘Onak’? Where had she heard that word before?

She blinked again as she remembered that ‘onak’ meant ‘goddess’.

Oh, no! Not again!

*****

Scouting Part 4

Unclaimed System, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Another Ha'tak self-destructed. "This isn't working," Samantha Carter said. "We can't secure the magazines fast enough to prevent them from blowing themselves up." Sokar's Jaffa must have orders to detonate the ordnance - or fuel; it didn't really matter much when it came to Naquadah-powered technology - at the first sign of enemies in the vicinity. Or at some pre-determined line or point. Or the order had them trigger the self-destruct if they lost contact with certain posts inside the ship.

"Wellllll…" Entrapta scrunched her nose. "Not unless we somehow find a way to knock all of them out at the same time. But that's difficult - they will have closed their hatches and bulwarks, and the ship's compartmentalised to avoid loss of atmosphere if a part of the hull is breached, so a stun gas won't work. Maybe a binary stun gas…"

"They might have rigged the detonators to dead man's switches," Sam pointed out. That's what she would have done if faced with such a threat.

"Oh. Well, in that case…" Entrapta shook her head. "Then we'd have to sneak in and disable that."

"If I could teleport in space, I could get into the magazines and then port the bombs out," Glimmer said. She didn't sound convinced of that, though.

"You can't teleport that many bombs," Bow objected.

Glimmer frowned. "Let's see if our prisoner is willing to talk, then."

Sam didn't think the odds of a maintenance technician - or the Jaffa equivalent to that post - and, apparently, a screwup in addition to that, would know rally spots or standing orders. But it wasn't as if they had many alternatives. "I'll attempt to hack the

next Ha'tak then. Remotely hack," she clarified when Glimmer looked at her with raised eyebrows. Sam hadn't considered doing it in person. Not seriously, at least. Besides, Glimmer had no room to talk with her teleport comment.

"OK."

"As long as we keep at it, we should succeed sooner or later," Entrapta said, but Sam could tell that her friend wasn't really optimistic either.

But there wasn't much else they could do. They had sent out the spy bots on the same course the missing Ha'tak had taken, but without further data, and accounting for the inherent variation of the vectors and the range of the bots' sensors, the network had a lot of space to cover. This could…

A beeping sound interrupted Sam's gloomy thought. A report from the spy bot network? She gasped.

"They've caught a message that may be from our friends!" Entrapta exclaimed.

"Playing it," Sam said, hitting a few keys.

"Scouting Party to Main Task Force. We've taken control of our ride, but we're stuck in space." That was the Colonel's voice! Sam blinked as she took a few deep breaths, hours of tension suddenly leaving. And coordinates followed!

She quickly switched the holographic map on and sent the coordinates to it. It was quite the distance - a quick mental calculation told her that the Colonel and the others would have only managed to disable the hyperdrive about half an hour ago.

"Call Priest!" Glimmer told Bow. "We need to get them at once!"

"Yes!" Bow replied. "Setting course for the flagship."

"Rerouting the spy bots to the area," Entrapta added as the shuttle picked up speed.

Sam softly sighed as she started coordinating the different sensor networks. The Colonel had done it again. Just as she had hoped, known, he would. Now all that was left was to reach them before the enemy did.

Which was… well, they had good odds of success. Horde frigates were faster than Goa'uld ships. But if the enemy's rally spot - or base - was close to the Ha'tak's position…

Sam clenched her teeth and redirected the spy bot network to focus on the projected course the Ha'tak had taken before it was stopped by the Colonel and their friends.

They were just setting down in the flagship's hangar when the first results came in - long-range signals being picked up. There weren't many signals, but their point of origin, according to estimates based on their strength, was far too close to the Colonel's position for Sam's comfort.

If the Ha'tak had an emergency beacon active instead of being disabled to prepare for Sokar's false flag operation…

Sam clenched her teeth again. This was going to be a close call. Far too close for her taste.

*****

Unknown Location, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We have established contact with the Main Task Force."

Catra, guarding the prisoners in the makeshift prison Adora had constructed, perked up at Teal'c's announcement. Yes! Their friends would be coming to get them now. Not that she had doubted it, of course. But it was good to get confirmation.

"Great, Teal'c," O'Neill commented on the comm. *"Did you notice any distress signal from our ship or any other communication?"*

"I did not, O'Neill. However, the communications equipment was slightly damaged, and even if it were working at full capacity, I could not exclude the possibility that the false god Sokar has had his followers install hidden beacons to find his ships, should they go missing."

Yeah. Catra nodded. For a paranoid bastard like Sokar, who couldn't track his minions through their minds, like Horde Prime had been able to, installing a device on a ship that regularly sent its position to his headquarters and not telling anyone of the crew would make sense. That way, he could appear to be all-knowing. Which had also been a stick of Horde Prime. Of course, he might have wanted that removed for a false flag operation. So, what would his paranoia have gone with? Increased control over his Jaffa or increased security?

Both, Catra concluded. Sokar could easily have the signal sent to an automated or otherwise expendable small ship stationed in the middle of nowhere and scrubbed of all signs of its owner. She could have done that. "We'll have to assume that there are such beacons," she spoke into her communicator.

"I concur," Teal'c said.

"Well, you're the expert." O'Neill didn't sound happy. *"But my gut agrees. We'll have company sooner or later."*

"Let's hope our friends get here first!" Adora, of course, was optimistic. *"For the Jaffa's sake as well,"* she added.

Catra smirked even though no one except, maybe, some of the prisoners in the room in front of her, could see it. "Yes, we wouldn't want to get any of your new faithful hurt, would we? That would be a black mark on your divine record."

"I'm no goddess!" her lover insisted at once, as Catra had known she would.

"I think Daniel would disagree," Catra retorted. "Didn't he point out that you match the definitions of a goddess according to some religions on Earth?"

"I'm no goddess!"

And there she was. Catra smirked again as she saw her lover appear in the hallway leading to her spot at the door to the prison area.

"I'm no goddess," Adora repeated herself for the third time, but off the comm, as she joined Catra. "I don't want anyone to worship me."

Catra shrugged. "I thought the plan was to convert them."

"I wanted them to stop worshipping the Goa'uld. I didn't want…" Adora pressed her lips together as the prisoners behind the bars they had jammed and spot-welded to block the door got up and stared at her, several bowing their heads. "...that."

"Win some, lose some. Partial success is better than a complete failure," Catra said. Of course, Adora had been raised to only ever consider complete success as an acceptable outcome…

Adora sighed. "I know, but that doesn't mean I like it. Why can't people just… stop worshipping anyone?"

Catra shrugged. "Some can, but I think most need something or someone to believe in." She grinned again. "And there are much worse people to believe in than She-Ra." And no one better, she added in her mind.

Adora pouted at her again, then turned to face the prisoners. "Hello! Is anyone in need of healing? I only healed the worst cases, but now I have the time time to heal everyone else."

For a moment, none of the Jaffa said anything. Not even Catra's ears could pick up a whisper from the room full of prisoners.

Then one of them glanced over his shoulder before addressing Adora: "We will soon recover fully, Onak. Except for Haken. He has lost his prim'ta."

Adora's eyes widened. "Oh, no!"

Catra clenched her teeth. That meant the Jaffa's immune system was failing - he was doomed. They had been afraid of… Her eyes widened. That meant the other larvae were fine - Adora's healing hadn't killed them! That was… that meant it was safe to heal Jaffa. Or Tok'ra. Possibly. A human host and a Jaffa were different, after all. Still, it was important to know that Adora couldn't accidentally kill a Jaffa by healing them.

Adora raised her chin and stepped directly in front of the door. "Come forth, Haken!"

The crowd of prisoners parted, some shying away from looking at her, and revealed a Jaffa sitting on the floor, one hand on his stomach. He got up, stumbling a little - was he already sick?

Adora summoned her sword - Catra heard many prisoners gasp and hiss at the sight - and pointed it at the Jaffa. A moment later, magic energy enveloped him.

He, too, gasped, even blinked, and stood straighter.

"I have cured you of whatever disease infected you. But without a, ah, prim'ta, you will keep getting infected, so I will have to keep healing you until we find a solution. We're working on that, though." Adora smiled at him.

"Th-thank you, Onak!" Haken fell on his knees, bowing.

So did several other Jaffa. A few hissed in obvious anger, but more seemed to be… holding back?

Catra had a feeling that even those who didn't want to abandon Sokar didn't question that Adora was a goddess.

She snorted softly. Her idiot lover just couldn't help it.

*****

"...and we're about to enter hyperspace, sir."

Carter sounded as professional as ever, in Jack O'Neill's opinion. Of course, the signal lag would help with that - having to wait a few seconds for a reply made it easier to prepare your response. Not that she would need such help. And, speaking of help… "Good to hear, Carter," he replied. "We're all wishing that we'll be able to get off this ship here before someone comes to repossess it. Oh, and prepare for a few hundred prisoners."

"Yes, sir. Entering hyperspace now."

It might have been his imagination, but this time, the signal lag seemed to be a second longer than usual. Jack grinned - if they pulled this off, this might even top the Apophis mission. Destroying one Ha'tak with a team of four was one thing, but taking it as a prize?

Don't count your chickens before they hatch, he reminded himself. Sokar's relief or clean-up forces might arrive before the task force did. And if they did… Well, there wasn't much that they could do about this. Except for what they were doing. He hit his radio button. "How's it going with Plan Bugout, Teal'c?"

"I am preparing the two crafts for launch, O'Neill. Although the bay is at quite a distance from the bridge, so in an emergency, our departure will be delayed some time."

Jack was aware of that. But absent a Stargate - and the ship didn't have a gate; they had checked thoroughly - a Death Glider was their best bet to escape being captured or killed by Sokar's ships.

It wasn't a very good bet, mind you - the ships were not able to enter hyperspace, and Sokar would send dozens of Death Gliders after them, and not even Teal'c had a lot of experience with flying

the things - but they only had to survive until help arrived. And a small chance was still better than no chance at all.

And Jack was Air Force. If he had to go down, then doing so behind the controls of a fighter wasn't the worst way to go. Surrendering to a snake who styled himself after Satan - or was the original Satan - was out of the question, of course.

Steps in the hallway made him turn away from the console and grip his carbine. It didn't sound like a Jaffa in armour, but better safe than sorry.

But it was Adora, and Jack relaxed as soon as he saw her step through the doorway. "We've got a problem," she said with a grimace. "More than one, actually."

Oh? That didn't sound good. But Jack shrugged - an officer had to project confidence, after all. "Well, what's a few more problems?"

"One of the prisoners lost his larva. I've healed him, but he'll keep getting sick," she explained.

"Ah." That wasn't really a problem, in his opinion. Unfortunate for the prisoner, but people died in war - and they had already killed a lot of Jaffa to take the ship. One more dying from lingering wounds wasn't going to make Jack lose any sleep. He didn't say that out loud, of course. Because Adora obviously considered it a problem, and Jack wasn't about to try and make the girl who could wreck starships single-handedly care less about normal people and collateral damage. "There's not much we can do about that," he said.

"No, we can't. We really need a solution for the Jaffa's immune system." Adora sighed and sat down on a broken console.

Definitely. If Adora planned to keep healing the prisoner until a solution was found, then that would seriously hinder the war effort. You couldn't drag a prisoner along on every mission. Of course, as the supreme commander of the Alliance, she shouldn't go on missions to begin with, so this might be a blessing in

disguise. But that could wait for now. “So, what’s the other problem? Or problems?” he asked.

“Some of the Jaffa think I’m a goddess.”

Jack raised his eyebrows. “Like Teal’c hoped for?”

Adora frowned at that. “Yes. But we already defeated them.”

“Which probably helped convince them.” Seeing a seven-foot-tall warrior princess shrug off your best shots as if they were nothing while she went through your ranks and then healed you afterwards of what should have been lethal wounds would be enough to make even some American soldiers reconsider their religion, in Jack’s opinion.

Judging by the way she narrowed her eyes at him but didn’t disagree, she thought the same. “But what do we do if the prisoners who are loyal to Sokar start attacking those who aren’t?” she asked.

It was Jack’s turn to wince. He hadn’t considered that - and, in hindsight, he should have. “That’s a problem, yes,” he admitted.

“We need a second prison to separate them,” Adora went on. “But what if some of them, ah, change their opinion after being separated?”

She was right - even dividing the prisoners now wouldn’t prevent such issues. And they couldn’t really spare the guards for two prisons. “Stun them all?” he suggested.

That earned him another frown. “Catra is planning to.”

Ah. Jack should have expected that - Catra was a fair bit more pragmatic than Adora. A bit more callous as well. He shrugged again, though with a sympathetic smile. “Then I can’t think of anything else. But our friends will soon arrive, and then we can hand the prisoners over to them.” And they should have the

facilities to handle the Jaffa - they had come prepared for prisoners, after all.

“Yes. But that still leaves the worship.” Adora pressed her lips together.

Some people would love to be worshipped as a god. Jack could think of several politicians. Or officers. But Adora hated it. Which Jack understood. But what could he say that wasn’t just a platitude? Priest and his clones hadn’t stopped treating her as a goddess despite her repeated denial. Jack didn’t think freshly converted Jaffa would be different. Converts were often the most fanatical followers of a religion.

He was almost glad for the alarm that broke the awkward silence. And Adora reacted as if she shared his sentiment.

*****

An alert? Adora wheeled around. The main screen of the Ha’tak’s bridge - they still didn’t know the ship’s real name, she realised - was broken from a stray staff blast, but there were still a few working screens on some of the consoles. And one of them was showing the ship’s surroundings - and radar contacts.

“What’s happening?” Catra asked over the comm.

“Several ships arrived in our vicinity,” Adora replied.

“Too soon to be our friends,” Jack added. She glanced at him and saw that he looked as tense as he sounded.

The display didn’t show the new contacts as hostile either. So it was probably… “Sokar.”

“If it’s anyone else, this would be an incredible coincidence.” Jack nodded.

So they had to be Sokar’s troops.

"Great. How many?" Catra went on.

Adora checked the data. She was no expert, but she had studied Goa'uld systems in preparation for this mission. "Four Ha'taks."

"Yep. Not very sporting of Sokar."

She glanced at him again. "Didn't you say that a fair fight is a sign you failed at war?"

"That was meant for us, not for the enemy." He snorted.

Catra spoke up again: *"We can't beat them in a fight. Not in a crippled ship and no crew."*

And probably not in a fully-working ship with a skeleton crew, either. Not at those odds. "We only have to last until our friends arrive. I can get out there and… fight." Though she didn't think she could do too much to a Ha'tak. Especially not if they kept their distance.

"Can you keep them from blowing the ship up while you're at it?" Jack asked.

No, she couldn't. She pressed her lips together.

"No, she can't," Catra said.

"Then we need to be tricky." Jack tilted his head.

"The Death Gliders are almost ready to launch," Teal'c reported.

Which meant they weren't ready. And the enemy ships were closing.

"Well, we know Sokar's cruel and paranoid. Let's hope he's also arrogant and curious," Jack said.

Catra snorted. *"You want him to investigate."*

“Yep.” Jack looked around on the bridge. “How much more time do you need, Teal’c?”

“The refuelling will take a few more minutes, O’Neill.”

“By that time, they’ll be too close to escape,” Jack said. “But… can you rig them to fly by themselves?”

“You wish for them to act like decoys.”

“Yes. And to explode upon capture or something. If Sokar or his commander thinks we left the ship and died, they probably won’t blow it up - if only to get more information about us.” Jack grinned at Adora. “And even if he suspects we hid, he might bet on being able to capture us.”

“Sounds like a good plan,” Catra said. *“Better than Adora going out there and trying to cut up Ha’taks.”*

Adora frowned, but her lover was correct. “But we need a good spot to hide in.”

“The ventilation ducts, of course,” Catra shot back at once.

The console beeped, and then a voice sounded from the speaker. Adora couldn’t understand the words - it was Goa’uld - but the gist was clear. A demand for information. Or for their surrender. Probably with a threat. Well, it wasn’t quite clear, but clear enough.

“And that’s our cue to move! Teal’c, launch the Death Gliders as soon as you can, then join us in…”

“...the main hub in the ventilation ducts.” Catra appeared in the doorway. “Hurry up!” She turned and headed back into the hallway.

Adora and Jack followed her. Behind them, the voice - it sounded like a Jaffa, not a Goa’uld - repeated their demands.

Adora clenched her teeth. If the Jaffa were about to blow up the ship, there would be nothing she could do about it. Everyone would die.

"Sokar's not going to blow us up right away," Catra said as if she had read Adora's thoughts. "He needs information. And I bet he wants to torture his enemies and make a big deal about it. So he can show off how powerful he is."

That sounded like Horde Prime. On the other hand, this was a false flag operation, and Sokar would be ready to cover up his involvement… But he didn't know what had happened to his fleet. He couldn't just blow them up and risk getting blindsided. He would have to know how they found his fleet.

Adora hoped she was right. They didn't have enough information to be sure.

Catra stopped below a ventilation duct's opening and jumped up, easily and gracefully slipping inside.

Adora looked at Jack.

"After you," he said, looking over his shoulder.

Adora hesitated a moment. She should bring up the rear - she could resist most of the Jaffa's weapons. But Jack knew what he was doing.

And if they turned out to be wrong about Sokar's aims, if the Jaffa outside decided to blow up the ship, then Adora wanted to be with Catra. Hold her.

She jumped, grabbed the edge of the opening, and pulled herself up and into the duct, crawling after Catra.

As Jack followed, muttering a curse under his breath, Teal'c announced over the communicator: *"Launching the Death Gliders."*

"Great. Join us here," Jack repeated.

And then they had nothing else to do but wait and hope they had guessed right.

*****

Hyperspace, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We're closing in on the location of Her Divine Highness. Our estimated time of arrival is five minutes and thirty-one point five seconds."

The clones had taken Samantha Carter's request to keep her informed with precise information almost literally. If they had been human, she would have suspected malicious compliance. But they sounded earnest and diligent as they kept her updated with information the computer of the stealth shuttle was already telling her. And since this was about rescuing Adora, amongst others, it was quite doubtful that they would resent her request.

She could have amended her request, but… a bit of redundancy never hurt anyone except, maybe, the budget. She snorted at her feeble joke. Not that the budget was a concern anymore, now that the entire world was aware of the war.

Shaking her head, she forced herself to focus on the screen in front of her again. Five more minutes until they would arrive at the coordinates of the Ha'tak the Colonel and the others had, apparently, taken. Part of her still felt this was an amazing feat, even though she should know better - she had seen what Adora could do in a fight. Entrapta, Glimmer and Bow certainly weren't surprised.

And yet, it could have all been in vain. If Sokar's fleet found the ship before their task force arrived… Or if they simply blew the ship up…. Or if someone in the crew of the ship managed to scuttle it…

"Don't worry! Adora is with them. She'll keep them safe."

Sam felt herself flush a little in embarrassment. For Entrapta to pick up her emotional state, Sam must have utterly failed to keep a calm facade. "I know," she forced herself to lie. "I still worry."

Entrapta nodded, smiled and turned back to her own computer.

Glimmer, though, only nodded at her with a grim expression. She would realise how perilous their friends' situation was. The princess was hovering behind them, torn between sitting in the shuttle's cockpit with Bow, ready to fly out of the flagships hangar as soon as they arrived, and sitting with Sam and Entrapta in front of their screens, to keep abreast of the situation.

The minutes ticked by, faithfully announced by a clone. Sam ran several calculations that she had already done just to keep busy. Maybe a simulation of a meeting engagement… Perhaps they should have dropped out of hyperspace on the way to get an update from the spy bot network's data… but that would have delayed their arrival. And Sam had no doubt that Priest's task force would charge in no matter the odds anyway.

As would she, of course.

"Estimated time of arrival in thirty seconds."

It was time. She took a deep breath and strapped herself into her seat as Glimmer headed back to the cockpit for the fifth time. Sam watched the countdown, watched the screen showing the task force's relative position to their destination. Five. Four. Three. Two. One.

The shuttle shuddered slightly as the frigate dropped out of hyperspace, and the sensor readings changed immediately.

"Contact! Hostile! Jamming field active!"

"For Her Divine Highness! Smite the Enemies!"

"Engaging!"

The sensor display lit up with enemy contacts. For a fraction of a second, Sam felt frozen. Then her fingers flew over the keyboard as she took in the data. Five Ha'taks. The rest of the contacts were Death Gliders. And four Ha'taks were surrounding a fifth, which was damaged. Analysis… "There they are!" she whispered, relief filling her - only to be replaced with dread as her sensor picked up debris near the crippled ship. A craft had been destroyed there. At least one. Had that been… No!

"Jammers are effective. Enemy communication is suppressed!" Entrapta announced.

"Find Her Divine Highness!"

They were already doing that! Sam gritted her teeth as she attempted to contact the Colonel. "Task Force to Scouting Party, respond. Task Force to Scouting Party, respond."

The Goa'uld ships were reacting to their arrival - Sam saw the Ha'taks starting to change formation on her screen, turning to face the attacking frigates, with the Death Gliders covering them. But the ships were too spread out - the vanguard of the task force opened fire on the closest Ha'tak before the other three could close ranks. The Goa'uld ship's shields shattered under the assault, and Sam held her breath as the frigates kept firing at it in passing.

But the fire was aimed at the ship's propulsion and weapon systems - the Ha'tak shuddered, debris being launched away by the hits, but didn't blow up.

"We're in range of the scanner! Scanning!" Entrapta reported.

Sam split her screen, one side showing the fleet battle as Horde fighters engaged Death Gliders in a hail of blaster fire, and the frigates sped towards the remaining Ha'taks, the other showing the scanner's data.

There! "The Scouting Party is on the damaged Ha'tak!" Sam snapped, transmitting the data to Priest.

"Destroy the enemy ships! Protect her Divine Highnesses's vessel!"

The clones changed tactics at once. The next Ha'tak, already under fire, blew up seconds after its shields failed as every frigate in range kept firing at it almost indiscriminately.

The two remaining enemy capital ships were starting to reverse course, trying to escape, but the task force was too close and too fast - and already splitting up to go after both of the ships simultaneously.

"Task Force to Scouting Party, respond!" Sam repeated herself. They were in range of the comms - even accounting for some interference from the jammers, and Goa'uld countermeasures, they should be able to…

"Scouting Party to Task Force. Good to hear you."

That was the Colonel! He was safe! Sam smiled - and blinked a few times to clear her eyes. "Task Force to Scouting Party, how's your situation?"

"We're holed up here inside the ship. Could use some help before the prisoners start trying to escape."

Sam checked the sensors. Enough Horde fighters had been launched to handle the Death Gliders. And the two Ha'taks wouldn't last much longer either. "We're coming!" she announced.

Their stealth shuttle was first out of the hangar, but half a dozen conventional shuttles packed with troops for boarding followed close on their heels.

A flight of Death Gliders tried to intercept them, but the shuttles were flying in close formation, and their blaster turrets made short work of the attackers.

Sam checked the sensors for more threats, then stared at the crippled Ha'tak looming bigger and bigger on their screens.

They were coming for their friends.

*****

Catra's ears picked up the sound of shuttles touching down on the Ha'tak's hulls and engaging their magnetic clamps. "They've arrived!" she announced, then sliced the grate in front of her open and slid through. A quick twist later, she landed on her feet in a hallway near the central shaft.

"We've docked and are about to hack the airlock!" Entrapta enthusiastically announced over the comm. *"Don't worry, we won't overlook the remote locking routine this time! Even though there shouldn't be anyone able to use them with you in control of the ship."*

"We're not on the bridge right now," Adora replied, joining her on the floor with a grunt. "But we've blocked the way, so it should be empty."

It better be empty - if anyone reached the bridge, they could do a lot of damage. At least they had disabled the comms, just in case, but if there was some secret scuttling charge… "Let's meet on the bridge," Catra said into her communicator.

"Yep," O'Neill agreed as he pushed himself out of the ventilation duct. "Not that someone else tries to claim our prize."

He hadn't said that on the comm, Catra noted with a grin.

"If you need assistance, we can blow our way into the ship at once, Your Divine Highness!"

"No, no!" Adora quickly told Priest - was he on one of the shuttles? Catra didn't think so, but she wouldn't put it past him. "We're fine here!"

"We've hacked the airlocks and are going in!" Entrapta reported a moment later.

Catra heard Adora's relieved sigh clearly and grinned.

"Zealots being enthusiastic with explosives…" O'Neill shook his head.

"I do not think that such a course of action would have endangered us," Teal'c said.

Catra cocked her head and held her hand up to silence the banter - were those shots she had heard?

"We've engaged hostile forces," a clone - not Priest - announced on the comm.

Definitely shots, then. And relatively close. "Must be stragglers," Catra commented. She nodded in the direction from which she heard the fighting. "It's not on the way, but…"

"Let's take them out so fewer people die!" Adora nodded with a firm expression and moved past Catra, then slowed down when she saw the junction ahead. "Uh…"

Catra grinned and slipped past her. "This way!"

They reached the fighting half a minute later. A dozen Jaffa were trying to stop twice their numbers of bots and clones. And their rear guard only noticed them when Adora ploughed into him and knocked him out.

Pincered - and under attack from Adora - the Jaffa didn't last long. Catra tasered the last one and looked around.

"Your Divine Highness!" The leading clone bowed deeply, followed by all the other clones. At least the bots didn't bow.

Catra blinked as the bots did bow. Priest must have had someone reprogram them.

And Adora was struck speechless for a moment.

"We're at the bridge. Where are you?" Entrapta asked

"We're coming!" Adora replied at once. "Take the prisoners - ah, take them with us!" she ordered the boarding party.

A quick walk and a short trip up the stairs later, they reached the bridge area. It was obvious that the barricaded doors hadn't stopped the others, but it was also obvious that no one else had reached the bridge before them.

"Adora!"

"Adora!"

"Catra! Adora! Friends"

"Sir."

"Jack! Teal'c!"

And here came the hugging. Catra let herself be pulled into the 'Best-Friends-Squad-Group-Hug', as Bow dubbed it. She knew better than to try to resist. And it felt kind of nice, anyway.

"Carter! Sorry about the mess - I wanted to get you an intact ship, but we kind of broke it."

"It may be fixable, sir. Although I would need to check on the hyperdrive's condition as well as the controls - it might require more time than we can spare."

Ah, how cute - both of them acting so professional - well, for O'Neill's version of professional - even though they wanted to hug each other as well. At least in Catra's opinion.

"I was forced to be a bit more thorough than planned in disabling the hyperdrive," Teal'c said, nodding at his friends. "In case the Jaffa had spare crystals."

"Ah." Sam nodded. "In that case, I really need to examine the damage."

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta slipped out of the hug, but she was cheating with her hair. "Let's check the hyperdrive!"

"And let's move the prisoners off the ship as soon as possible," O'Neill added. "We want them - and us - back on a working ship before more enemies arrive."

"Yes, sir."

And with that, the hug ended for everyone. Catra trailed her tail over Adora's leg as she stepped back. The hard part was over. Now just the clean-up remained.

*****

"We got them. Both down, lightly wounded. Not enough for Adora to heal them, but she did it anyway. They could have healed up by themselves, idiot!"

"There was no need to have them suffer longer than they should."

"Don't complain if they start worshipping you! Anyway, are there any more stragglers left?"

Leaning against a piece of undamaged all on the bridge, Jack O'Neill looked at Entrapta.

"Not according to our scanner!" the princess announced. "And we found no data that would indicate that they developed a way to fool our scanner, so there's a very low chance that there are still Jaffa hiding out in the ship."

That didn't mean there was no chance at all, of course - Jack was aware of that. But if Sokar had the technology to fool their magic scanner, and the knowledge that it was needed to deploy it, the whole mission would have gone very, very differently from the

start. Namely, Jack doubted that the stealth shuttle would have reached the enemy ship.

So, if the scanner said the ship was clean, it was good enough for him. He switched his microphone on. “Alright, get the prisoners ready for transport.” With the shuttles actually docked, that meant they didn’t have to stuff them into vacuum-proof bodybags. “Carter, how’s it looking with the hyperdrive?”

“The damage is repairable. We have all the necessary spares. Restoring the power will take a while, though. And I have some concerns about the structural stability of the ship after the damage it took.”

“Sorry! I wasn’t very careful when I had to save Catra!”

“You didn’t have to save me! I was doing fine!”

“You had to save Catra?”

“No, Sparkles, she didn’t.”

“Yes, I did, Glimmer. She was hurt!”

“It was a scratch!”

Jack shook his head as he tuned out the bickering. He didn’t think that the damage Adora had done by cutting through the decks would be a problem. But coupled with all the other damage done during the fighting, including Catra and Teal’c’s sabotage… “Can we, ah, tow the ship if we have to?” he asked Entrapta.

“Uh…” She cocked her head to the side. “I don’t think the frigates are equipped for that. Their hyperdrives can’t carry such a big ship along - we’d have to modify them, but constructing a transport ship would probably be easier. And safer. And more efficient since such a modified hyperdrive would draw more power even without a ship to tow. So… maybe? If we have enough time? Though repairing the ship would probably be faster, I think. Provided the structural integrity can handle more flight operations.

Fixing that would, hm… I think it would take much longer. I did it for Darla since she was buried in the desert for a thousand years, but Darla is much smaller than this ship. And I still had to do a lot of maintenance fixing her. Still do, actually."

Jack nodded even though he only got the gist of it - no towing Ha'taks. Entrapa wasn't Carter. His second-in-command would have summed up all the relevant information clearly and succinctly. "So, we either can get it moving, or we have to scuttle it."

He pressed his lips together, annoyed at himself for slipping and using a naval term. He wasn't a Navy Puke.

"Yes! But it would be a shame to destroy such a beautiful ship! The style's completely different from the Horde style - or the First Ones', like Darla." Entrapta beamed at him, then at the bridge. "I am sure we can fix her better than new!"

Jack was also sure that Entrapta and Carter could do it. He was less sure that they should spend their time fixing a Ha'tak, though. But he didn't think his opinion would matter - Earth would jump at the chance to get a spaceship of their own, especially one upgraded to Horde specs.

But the war this would trigger over who got to crew and command it… He had to snicker at the thought of a Royal Navy captain standing in the middle of a golden bridge. Now, if they had to wear Goa'uld uniforms…

But, speaking of Goa'uld… He looked at Entrapta again. "No luck on finding a snake larva? A live one, I mean." You had to be precise with her.

Entrapta blinked, then shook her head. "No. We only picked up dead ones on the scanner. We weren't fast enough to save them, sorry."

Which meant the Jaffa who had lost his would keep depending on Adora's healing. Which she would feel obligated to provide. Damn.

“And I bet that the Tok’ra don’t have any to spare, either.”

“I don’t think so.” Entrapta cocked her head to the side again. “Anise never mentioned the need for Jaffa, only for hosts for adult Tok’ra. I don’t think they reproduce, actually. Which would be a huge problem for their long-term survival, wouldn’t it?”

“Well, they have managed for a few thousand years…” Jack shrugged. “But if they don’t have enough hosts as things are, they might not want more competition for hosts by growing more of them.”

“That would make sense. We’ll have to ask them!”

Jack grimaced. Kids were about the last subject he wanted to talk about with the Tok’ra. “Yeah, sure, you do that,” he mumbled.

He pushed off the wall and straightened. “I’ll go check on Carter.”

Entrapta looked puzzled, but Daniel, who was translating what manuals they had found, had a stupid grin on his face as Jack walked past him.

He rolled his eyes. Carter was his subordinate. He was just checking up on her as any good officer would.

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Scouting Part 5

Deep Space, January 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and so the ship can be restored to a state where it should be able to safely travel through hyperspace. The hyperdrive is easily fixable, as I've reported before, but the reactor needs more extensive repairs."

Adora nodded as Sam finished her report. That wasn't really a surprise.

"Their fault for placing the main reactor close to the magazines." Catra leaned back on her chair and stretched her arms over her head.

"It also served as a fuel tank. Well, sort of - it's not exactly as if they would just shovel Naquadah into their reactors like we've seen in some movies, but the material serves as a base for both their weapons and propulsion. And power supply. And it's a tiny bit volatile if you nudge it just enough with the right kind of stimulus, so it makes sense to keep it all in one place," Entrapta said. "Because if your Naquadah storage gets hit by a blaster cannon… Boom!" She puffed up her cheeks and mimed an explosion with her hands. "That way, you only have one such weakness instead of two. Or more. It's just good engineering."

"Well, it's still not my fault." Catra shrugged. "We had to keep them from blowing us up."

Adora nodded again. The others had told them about the Jaffa suiciding when they were boarded. If they hadn't secured the magazines… She shuddered.

"Yes, but that still means our shiny, almost new spaceship isn't so shiny any more," Jack said.

"It's actually an old ship, sir," Sam told him. "It was maintained well, and there were some revisions and upgrades compared to

the original design, but it was built before Sokar's disappearance. The logs have been tampered with, so we can't pin down where it was built, but we could determine its age."

"Well, it makes sense that Sokar wouldn't use newer ships on a false flag mission. They were probably expendable, seeing as how his Jaffa blew them up so quickly," Glimmer commented.

"Yeah," Catra chimed in. "You don't use your best material for that. Or your best troops. Unless it's so important, you can't risk failure. Or you can't trust your expendable troops to suicide before capture." She narrowed her eyes at the others, who were glancing at her, Adora saw. "I didn't make troops suicide. But in a war, you have to sacrifice soldiers sometimes."

Not if I can help it, Adora thought.

"That's why princesses lead from the front," Glimmer said.

Bow nodded, as did Teal'c, but Adora could see that Jack looked… well, he wasn't frowning, but he was doing that expression as if he had bit on something sour and was trying not to show it. And Sam was a bit too busy looking at her computer.

Daniel cleared his throat. "But sacrificing yourself might lead to more people dying in the long run."

"Whatever," Jack spoke up before Adora could reply. "The question is: do we have time to repair the ship to take with us, or not? Carter?"

Sam pressed her lips together. "I am sorry, sir, but fixing the reactor will take more than a few hours. A straight replacement would be possible, but we don't have a spare reactor with the output needed to power a Ha'tak's system. We could use a frigate's reactor, but that would mean we'd sacrifice a massively more capable ship for a ship that needs extensive upgrades to be competitive. And hooking up several smaller power sources, such as shuttle reactors, would require replacing the power lines or minor fluctuations could wreck the entire setup."

Glimmer shook her head. “Since we have to assume that this location is known to Sokar’s forces, the longer we stay, the higher the chance that he will send more forces - including scouting vessels.”

Jack nodded slowly. “And that would risk ruining the surprise.” He shrugged. “Well, bringing a prize ship back would probably just have led to a huge argument over who got to keep it. It’s still a shame we can’t take it with us after all the trouble we went through to get it.”

Adora nodded in agreement, even though she thought this sounded a bit like… ‘sour grapes’, Daniel had called it.

Catra scoffed. “It’s a broken piece of crap. Even if it were brand new, Entrapta and Sam would have to spend weeks upgrading it so it wouldn’t be a liability in a battle.”

“It could have served as a training ship for Earth troops,” Sam pointed out.

Entrapta nodded. “And it looks cool. Do we really have to destroy it?” She looked at them with wide eyes.

Adora nodded, if a bit reluctantly.

“We have to destroy all traces of our presence,” Catra told their friend. “And there’ll be more ships we can board and take.”

“But they all kept blowing up!”

“We’ll solve that issue.” Catra grinned. “And you can probably build a training ship.”

“Oh, right! I have a few ideas about that already. We could crew it with bots that can show people how to handle it!” Entrapta nodded. “We can even make it look like a pyramid!”

Adora winced. “Ah, I think it would be better if it didn’t look like a Goa’uld ship.”

"I think it would be better if its design were, ah, inspired by Earth prototypes," Sam added.

"Right!" Entrapta nodded. "Or we could take one of the prototypes and modify it."

Jack cleared his throat. "Anyway, before we go into spaceship design, let's blow up the ship and all the evidence and leave?"

"Yes." Glimmer nodded.

"Let me call Priest," Adora said, trying not to wince. Priest's reaction to some of the Jaffa converting to worshipping She-Ra had been… enthusiastic.

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"Of course, Your Divine Highness! Your word is our holy command! Your will shall be done! None of Your faithful shall be harmed by those who still scorn Your divine guidance and wisdom despite the evidence of Your grace and divine blessing. We will not falter in our vigil over the prisoners and do our best to turn them to Your divine light! Without violating their rights, of course - participation in prayers will be purely voluntary, as Your holy decree demands!"

"Thank you, Priest."

Samantha Carter slightly grimaced in sympathy as she watched Adora close the connection to the bridge again. And to think she had wondered why Priest wasn't taking part in their conference…

"Ah… as you heard, the prisoners are ready for transport back to Earth." Adora winced. "They've been separated and will be monitored."

"And preached at," the Colonel added.

Adora winced again. "If they want to, ah, take part in, ah..."

"Worshipping you?" Catra raised her eyebrows with a smirk, seemingly unimpressed by her lover's scowl. Sam had wondered more than once about the dynamics of their relationship. Sometimes, it seemed as if Catra would do anything Adora wanted, no matter the cost, and sometimes, she acted… well, like this, teasing even though she knew her lover hated the situation.

Then Catra's expression changed as she leaned forward, looking straight at her lover and breathed more than said: "Well, who wouldn't want to worship you?"

Adora blushed terribly. "Ah…"

And sometimes, a bit too often for Sam's sense of professionalism and her slight envy, they acted like that.

"Well, worshipping voluntarily or not, this could set a bad precedent. You betcha that if we let one, ah, church convert our prisoners, every other church will want to do the same," the Colonel pointed out.

Daniel replied as Sam had known he would: "Actually, Jack, not all, not even most Christian churches are sending out missionaries. And that goes for many other religions as well - outside the Christian and Muslim faith, few religions focus on converting others." He pushed his glasses up his nose. "And even amongst those churches that emphasise converting others, there's a debate whether or not aliens actually would be, ah, suitable targets."

"You mean, they haven't yet decided if aliens have souls," the Colonel commented. "But enough of them have decided that aliens are people too that we'll get trouble from them."

Sam had to agree with that assessment. The religious right in America had lost some of their influence in the wake of the rush to join the Alliance, but they remained an important factor in national politics. If they pressed for 'equal opportunities' to

convert aliens, a number of politicians might see this as an easy concession.

“Why would there be trouble?” Teal’c calmly asked. “If more Jaffa break with their faith in false gods, that will help our struggle to end the Goa’uld.”

“Earth’s history is full of trouble related to religious differences,” the Colonel replied. “Usually bloody ones.”

“That’s a bit simplified,” Daniel said. “Religion has been, and continues to be, an important factor in society - and conflicts - but it’s merely one factor amongst many and often subsumed or instrumentalised by other interests. Granted, sometimes, that relationship changes, and religious interests and motivations might take over, but we cannot simply assume that letting missionaries talk to captured Jaffa will be harmful. And, of course, there’s the principle of the thing - it would be unjust and unfair if we favoured one religion above the others. It’s in the constitution, after all - well the constitution of the United States.”

“I’m no goddess,” Sam heard Adora mutter. “I don’t want a religion.”

“But you have one,” Catra said.

Glimmer nodded - at Daniel. “Yes. We have to treat everyone equally. But we also have to ensure that the war effort won’t be endangered by this. So, only those, ah, missionaries we can trust, those with sufficient security clearances, as you call it, can be granted access to the prisoners.”

That was an aspect Sam hadn’t considered yet - such missionaries would make perfect spies. Or saboteurs.

“They won’t like that,” the Colonel said. But he was grinning. “But we can excuse a lot with the war. It’s even tradition.”

Daniel, of course, pouted at that but didn’t disagree.

"And I bet the other religions aren't a competition for the Church of the Holy She-Ra," Catra commented with a wide grin. "The prisoners have seen and felt your holy touch, Adora. That's a huge advantage compared to some preacher with a book full of weird stories. Don't worry - you won't lose any worshippers."

She was obviously joking - even Adora was pouting and half-heartedly protesting that it wasn't funny instead of scowling at her lover - but Sam caught Teal'c nodding in agreement.

And while her friend was hard to read, she couldn't help feeling that he was more serious than Catra about that. And he had proposed trying to convince Sokar's Jaffa that Adora was a goddess in the first place.

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Hyperspace, January 29th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra finished skimming the preliminary report covering the loot from the Ha'tak - mostly anything that had decent amounts of Naquadah in it and all the weapons they had found - and leaned back, craning her neck to look at the desk behind her. Adora was dutifully *writing* a report.

"You're the Supreme Commander. People report to you, not the other way around," Catra reminded her idiot.

"I have to set an example for the rest. We need the best intel we can get - and that means collecting all information we gathered," Adora told her without looking up from her work.

"And writing all the boring reports?" Catra snorted.

"Yes." Glimmer, of course, had to butt in. "Have you even started on your reports?"

"Already finished them." Catra flashed her fangs in a wide grin. Then she rolled her eyes at the apparent surprise on Glimmer's face. "I've run the Horde for years; I know how to do reports."

“You never liked doing it as a cadet.” Adora had put her pad down and was frowning at her.

“That was just busywork,” Catra retorted. “Actually important reports are something else.”

“So, why are you teasing me about doing this?” Adora pouted.

“Because you’re overdoing it, of course. And I wasn’t kidding when I said you should be reading reports more than writing them. Then you’d have known I already finished my part.” Catra grinned as she saw her lover starting to scroll through menus on her pad.

“Ah… there is your report.”

“Yes.” Focused on the important parts.

While Adora - and Glimmer, from the looks of it - went over her report, Catra shifted on her seat. “We really need a Stargate for the fleet. Or a couple of them. Enough so we can assign one to any task force we send out. Then we could use them to get to the fleet once it arrives at its destination and later return to Etheria or Earth instead of travelling through hyperspace for weeks both ways. Or having to find a planet with a Stargate we can use in the vicinity for the return trip.”

“It’s not quite that long,” Adora half-heartedly replied.

“Maybe not this time, but what about next time?” Catra shook her head.

Glimmer agreed. “I would allow us to keep up a greater operational tempo if we could move princesses through a Stargate from one task force to another.”

“We can do that by flying to an empty system and using the Stargate there,” Adora said. “If time is of the essence. And even if we have a Stargate on a ship, we still need to be in a system for the coordinates to work.”

“And that might get noticed.” Bow apparently had decided to enter the conversation as well. “But if we use existing Stargates, then someone might be able to track us - or at least gather intel that way.”

Catra nodded. Like knowing where their task forces were. Or just realising that someone was sending people through those Stargates. Someone with a fleet. It wouldn’t take much to place surveillance near such gates - and even taking them out would reveal something. “It would be better to just grab a few Stargates and use them - we can use a stealth ship if we have to go near an inhabited system.”

“Yes, that would work,” Adora agreed. She was still frowning, though. “But it would also remove the Stargate from a world.”

“An empty world,” Glimmer shrugged. “No big loss.”

“It still feels wrong…” Adora trailed off.

“It’s not like stealing the galaxy’s magic to win a war,” Catra said. “No one is using those gates anyway.”

Adora flushed. “It still feels like it. Those Stargates don’t belong to us. They were placed on those planets for a reason.”

“Five million years ago,” Glimmer objected. “Whatever reasons they had, odds are the reasons for those Stargates are long gone.”

“They probably seeded every planet that might develop intelligent life,” Bow said. “Or this was part of a galaxy-wide colonisation program.” Adora winced at that. Which prompted Bow to wince as well, Catra noticed. “Sorry,” he added.

“It’s not…” Adora shook her head.

“Anyway,” Catra spoke up, “we’re not going to rob people of their Stargates - unless they’re Goa’uld - but no one will miss a Stargate in an empty system. And we can put them back once

we've won the war if you really want to." Which would be stupid, but Adora did a lot of stupid things. And now for the killing blow. "And it means you won't have to stay on a ship with Priest for weeks."

Glimmer snickered, and even Bow chuckled at that. Adora blinked, then flushed again. "Don't remind me!" she blurted out. Then she sighed. "Though it hasn't been bad. Not as bad as I expected. I thought he'd ask me to make regular appearances with the prisoners, but he didn't."

"Why would he, when you have to heal that prisoner without his larva every day?" Catra snorted. Priest was far sneakier than some people thought.

"His name is Haken," Adora reported. Then she blinked again. "Oh. I should have realised…"

"The humble, caring goddess, coming by daily to ensure a single Jaffa prisoner doesn't die…" Catra trailed off with a shrug. "It certainly shows that you aren't like the Goa'uld."

Adora shook her head. "But that's…"

"...just the truth," Glimmer cut her off. "We aren't like the Goa'uld. And we care about others - even about prisoners."

Adora frowned for a few seconds, then sighed. "I'm just doing what's right. I'm not doing this to manipulate anyone."

"And that's why it works." Catra snorted. "Anyway, are we passing by some empty systems on the way back?"

"Let me check the charts!" Bow replied. "But we could make a small detour - especially if we can get the Stargate to work on the ship; then we could easily make up the time spent on that. And if we can't move the Stargate, we might still use it on the planet to return home faster. Though we would have to take Haken with us in that case."

Catra leaned over and squeezed Adora's thigh as Bow started to look through his pad's data.

"I don't want to be worshipped," Adora said.

Catra nodded. "I know."

But Adora also didn't want to tell others what - and whom - they could worship and not. So, in a way, it was her own fault.

Not that Catra would blame her for it. Never.

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PZ-825, January 30th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Stay sharp, folks! You never know what might be hiding on a planet!" Jack O'Neill announced as the shuttle set down on the alien planet.

"Do you think that there's something on the planet that can fool our scanner? Or someone? An advanced civilisation? No, remnants of an advanced civilisation, maybe? Or First Ones? We should be able to detect First Ones technology that we know of, but they should have lots of technology that we don't know of, and they weren't limited to magic-less technology for a thousand years - not that the Goa'uld made a lot of progress even before the First Ones started taking all the magic, but that's probably because they don't have the talent to use magic, so the basic hypothesis is sound. I think." Entrapta sounded eager rather than miffed at the idea that Jack was doubting her and Carter's scanner. She hopped off the ramp before it was fully lowered and looked around.

Jack forced himself to smile as he stepped off the ramp, carbine ready. He didn't really doubt the scanner's reliability, but complacency killed. Soldiers should never blindly trust their tech or intel. Not that he thought SG-1 or the Etherians would grow complacent. But others would, and reminding your team to be wary on alien planets was standard procedure for good officers. A least in his opinion.

“We haven’t detected any signs of a civilisation,” Carter said, joining Entrapta on the ground. “And we scanned the surrounding area thoroughly.”

“We wouldn’t be here if there was a sign of people,” Adora added.

“We would have ignored a new civilisation?” Entrapta gasped. “But think of the data we could gather and share! The technology they might have!”

Adora grimaced. “I meant we wouldn’t be here to take the Stargate if we had detected a civilisation. We would have contacted them directly.”

Jack snorted. If the planet was settled, that would have complicated things. This world was far too close to Sokar’s fleet, as far as they knew, to just leave it at the mercy of a snake who thought Hell on Earth was a goal instead of a warning.

But unless there was some vast civilisation hiding underground, shielded from the best scanners Entrapta and Carter could cook up, this planet was empty of people. The perfect target for a grab-and-run. “Well, let’s go and nab us a Stargate before the planet’s animals evolve into people or something and demand to keep it.”

For some reason, Carter frowned at him for that. Daniel as well. Oh! Jack winced. The Ancients had crossed animals with people on Etheria.

Catra snorted, probably at his reaction instead of his joke. “Yeah, let’s go and grab the gate. Adora needs some exercise.”

“I don’t!” Adora blinked, then looked down at her body. “Do I?”

“No, you don’t,” Glimmer said. “But some people need to learn to make better jokes.”

Jack was pretty sure that included him. He shrugged - guilty as charged. But he was a little too old to change too much.

“Unfortunately, stand-up comedy courses were already closed when I was at the Airforce Academy.”

Daniel, at least, chuckled at that.

“Whatever. Let’s go!” Glimmer said.

They marched up the hill that separated them from the Stargate’s location. They could have landed directly at the gate, but… Even with a fleet in orbit, ready to blow the slightest threat to their goddess to smithereens, you didn’t want to risk your shuttle. Especially not an expensive prototype stealth shuttle.

When they reached the top of the hill, Jack dropped prone and crawled the last few yards through the tall grass until he could look at the Stargate in the valley below with his binocs.

“Looks deserted,” Catra commented next to him.

“Looks can be deceiving,” Jack retorted. Mostly to be contrarian, if he was honest.

“Let’s not be paranoid,” Glimmer said behind them. “We can just go down, check it out, then call the transport shuttle in and load it up.”

The princess was correct. Jack got up. “Alright, let’s go.”

They moved down the hill in patrol formation, Catra in front, followed by Jack, Adora, Carter, Entrapta, Daniel, Emily, Glimmer, Bow and Teal’c bringing up the rear. Good practice, again.

But nothing jumped at them until they reached the Stargate. No one discovered a pit trap by falling into it, either.

And the Stargate looked fine as well. Everything was where it should be, the D.H.D. was next to it, the ramp was covered in grass, and… Jack frowned and knelt down. “Someone’s used the gate recently,” he announced, pointing at the ramp. “All the grass has been cut off at the same height relative to the Stargate.”

“The vortex would have disintegrated all plants in its path,” Carter said, joining him. She looked at the grass, then at the Stargate. “Some time has passed, though - the tips of the grass have grown beyond the vortex’s limit.”

“Let’s check the data logs!” Entrapta walked over to the D.H.D.

Jack, meanwhile, looked at the overgrown ramp again. He couldn’t see any tracks. So, either the grass trampled down had recovered, the travellers had left no tracks - or they hadn’t come through the gate in the first place. At least not on foot.

But whatever actually had happened didn’t change the fact that the planet might be deserted, but someone had shown an interest in it recently. And they would notice that the Stargate was missing if they tried to dial it again.

That slightly complicated things.

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“So… someone used the gate a few weeks ago?” Adora asked, looking at the Stargate’s ramp. As Jack had pointed out, there were no tracks. Bow had confirmed it - and Bow was the best tracker she knew.

“If the rate of growth of this grass is comparable to the average rate of growth of Earth species under similar circumstances, yes,” Sam said.

Perfuma would probably be able to confirm that if she were here. But…

“I’m trying to access the gate’s logs,” Entrapta said. “Shouldn’t take much longer.”

“It would be funny if it turns out that this was just a mistaken address and no one actually arrived,” Catra commented, stretching her arms over her head and twisting her hips.

Adora pursed her lips. That would be a plausible explanation if no one actually had travelled through the gate. If it was a check to see if the Stargate was still working, whoever was doing this would have sent someone or something through to ensure the location wasn't dangerous. At least Adora would have done so in their place - a working gate was useless if you died upon stepping through it.

"Got it!" Entrapta beamed. "Alright, there was a matter transfer. So, someone got through the gate and back. The memory banks didn't log too many details, though - whoever created them really should have cared a tiny bit more about proper documentation! You can't really check experiments if you don't log everything!"

"What did you find out?" Glimmer asked.

"Oh! Well, I got the address of the Stargate that connected to this Stargate. They dialled in and then dialled out about… three weeks ago." Entrapta smiled. "With an hour between."

"A quick trip to check something," Jack said. "In and out before anyone notices. When was the trip before that?"

"No logs about that, sorry." Entrapta shrugged. "So, it must have been a pretty long time ago."

"There are limits to the device's logs," Sam explained before Adora could ask. "After a certain time, logs will be deleted. And the buffer only stores a set number of trips. We think it might be related to a window during which the original data is still viable for compensating for stellar drift."

"Where did those visitors come from?" Jack asked.

"We don't have any information about the system they used, sir," Sam told him. "Except for its coordinates."

"It's a mystery!" Entrapta beamed. "But a mystery we can solve just by dialling and checking ourselves!"

“And then we find out it was a recon team from Sokar when we walk into his throne room.” Jack shook his head.

“We can send a spy bot through before we use the gate,” Entrapta retorted.

“That would connect us to the disappearance of his fleet,” Catra pointed out. “Sokar won’t be able to identify us, but he would know it was someone with different technology. And if he is familiar with Horde technology…” She inclined her head.

Adora winced. That would expose them. Sure, no one expected their cover to last forever, but the longer they could keep the Goa’uld guessing, and suspecting their rivals, the better.

“We can build a spy bot based on Goa’uld technology! They wouldn’t know it was us, then!” Entrapta was looking at her with pleading eyes, Adora realised.

“They would suspect a rival, then,” Daniel said.

“They would also attempt to copy the bot,” Jack objected.

“If it’s Sokar,” Glimmer said. “It could be anyone else.”

“Right. But if we dial in from here, whoever it is will be able to connect us to the recent battle in the vicinity. So, we aren’t going to do that,” Jack said.

Adora caught Catra glancing at her. She knew what her lover was thinking - this wasn’t Jack’s decision. As the Supreme Commander, it was ultimately up to her. But Jack was right. “Yes,” Adora said. “We’ll check up on this a bit later. And in a way that won’t expose us.”

“I guess we could send in spy bots through the network…” Entrapta sounded disappointed, but there was no helping it. They couldn’t risk being exposed just to satisfy their curiosity.

“Let’s call the shuttle then,” Catra said.

“Yes.” Adora looked at the Stargate. “And let’s prepare the gate for travel.” The chance that someone would dial in while the gate was in the shuttle but still close enough to the planet so the address would be working was low, but if it happened and the vortex formed, it could destroy the entire shuttle. Best to block the gate for transport.

While Jack called the transport shuttle and the stealth shuttle, Adora looked at the Stargate, then at the area around them.

It still felt as if she was robbing the world of its birthright. Without the Stargate, the planet would probably never get more visitors. On the other hand, it might develop without interference then. Who knew what the visitors had done… She blinked. “Oh.” Turning to her friends, she asked: “What if the visitors left something on this world?”

“We should have detected any advanced technology with our scanner,” Sam said.

“First Ones, Horde or Goa’uld,” Entrapta added. “Although…” She looked at Sam. “Unknown technology might not have been detected. Especially if it doesn’t use Naquadah.”

“The basic principles remain the same for all technology,” Sam retorted. “Any technology needs a power source, which we would have detected. Although… there are systems that do not have an internal power source. They are powered from the outside. Or by what they are observing.”

“Oh! Like a passive detector? Maybe based on chemical reactions to a certain waveform?” Entrapta beamed.

“That would be one possibility.” Sam nodded.

“Let’s check once the shuttle arrives!”

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Samantha Carter didn't really expect their search to produce results. Passive detectors were tools for spies infiltrating a hostile planet, not an empty world devoid of any sapient life, much less an advanced civilisation. And, lacking internal power sources - which their scanner would have picked up - they would need to be visited regularly to get the results read out. Not something really suitable to catch enemy troop movements on a deserted planet - not in time to react to them, at least; the logs didn't show such regular visits.

But Sam had been wrong before, and such a detector would explain the visit by the unknown party. It would also grant them some clues about the identity of the travellers - the only alternatives were a gate mission or sending a spy bot or scout ship to the system. The far simpler explanation, of course, was that someone was exploring the Stargate network, like Stargate Command had been doing and still was doing, although severely constrained for security reasons. A Stargate team arriving here would have taken a look around and would have left again after finding nothing. If there were no obvious depots of valuable resources - and there weren't; they had scanned for that already - then Stargate Command wouldn't have bothered with a follow-up mission unless to provide new members with an easy and safe task to get them used to gate travel.

"Ah, there it is!" Entrapta waved as the stealth shuttle set down. "I think we should scan for all amounts of metal and crystal so we don't miss tiny detectors!"

"We need a minimum amount, though, or we'll be flooded with hits for all the trace amounts in the environment," Sam pointed out. "That's why we filter the data."

"Right! But we can lower that amount! Oh! We could also use a filter to check for trace amounts of foreign substances in the air!"

"Something with a finer filter than our standard sensors." Sam nodded. She still didn't think this would lead to much, but it was a

good way to refine standard operating procedures and think about improvements.

They entered the shuttle and headed to their 'travelling lab'. It was, to quote Entrapta, 'time to do science'.

*****

"Look at that! It's a tiny bit of metal - of an alloy!" Entrapta's head bopped up and down as she pointed at the screen with her finger and hair.

Sam checked the readings. Indeed, there, about one kilometre from the Stargate, in the middle of a rock formation laced with iron ore, was an object made from an advanced steel alloy. *Very* advanced. Too small to be considered a threat, no sign of any advanced power supply - or any power at all. "We'll have to adjust the scanner for such devices," she said.

"And we have to examine it!" Entrapta beamed before she blinked and frowned. "Or would that be rude? It would be rude to sabotage the experiment of someone else, wouldn't it?"

"Yes. But people doing experiments don't hide their sensors like that," Sam pointed out. "We can and should examine this - it could be the work of our enemies."

"Really? There's no Naquadah in the alloy. The Goa'uld use it for everything."

"Exactly. So, if a Goa'uld wanted to remain secret, avoiding technology that used Naquadah would help them," Sam explained.

"Oh, right." Entrapta nodded. "And if they actually have alternatives to their technology, that would be interesting! And bad, of course. But very interesting!"

Sam had to agree - someone had gone to great lengths to hide this object. It could be a passive detector, but it could also be data storage. Maybe a dead drop - but then, the Stargate logs should

show more activity. Unless it was meant as a sort of dead man's switch, to be discovered in case the one who left it died.

Sam smiled. It was indeed interesting. "Let's go and take a closer look."

It didn't take them long to reach the location, just twenty minutes - and that included the Colonel and Catra combing the area for ambushes and traps, even though they had scanned for either thoroughly.

But they could, finally, examine the object. It was not a box - it was a network of very thin threads, laid into solid rock. And linked to tiny crystal structures. Something about the array… Sam frowned as she took a closer look at the intricate design.

"Oh! All the crystals are attuned the same way! Definitely artificial!" Entrapta exclaimed.

They already knew that since alloys such as the one here didn't occur naturally, but confirmation was always good. But the array… Oh! "It's an antenna!" Sam blurted out.

"Yes, that's it," Bow agreed. "And if we examine the crystals, we can find out what kind of waveform it's meant for!"

"And we can replicate it and see what happens!" Entrapta added.

With their scanner, it didn't take them long to find out what the antenna reacted to. It was a form of FtL wave - which meant communication or sensors. Or both.

"It's not a standard frequency, but I think we can replicate a signal with our communicator," Entrapta said. "Shouldn't take long…"

Replicate it? Without further study of the array? "I don't think…" Sam started to say.

Entrapta, unfortunately, was quicker. “Ah! Here we go!” She pushed a button on the communicator she had fiddled with.

A moment later, the entire array, threads and crystals, lit up.

Literally.

Sam managed to look away a moment before the thing melted.

*****

Catra was already halfway to the ground when the thing Entrapta, Sam and Bow had been fawning over began to melt. Whatever it was, if something started glowing so brightly, it hurt to look at, you took cover. Even Kyle had learned that.

But the thing didn’t explode - it just sort of flowed out of the rock as a small stream of melted metal, leaving a tiny, sizzling puddle on the ground.

As far as self-destruct devices went, this was one of the tamer ones. It hadn’t even blown up the rock and anyone tampering with it. Of course, if that light show had involved harmful radiation… “What was that?” Catra asked. Loudly.

“Bow!” Glimmer rushed towards him.

“I’m OK!” He got up.

As did Entrapta, rubbing her eyes as her hair pulled out her recorder. “Note: Add an automatic polarising response to my visor in case of too bright light.”

“Is everyone alright?” Adora looked almost frantic as she hovered over the others. “What was that?”

“We found the frequency that the device reacted to,” Entrapta said, blinking heavily.

“And then we tested it a bit hastily,” Bow added.

“Sorry!” Entrapta didn’t look sorry. She was already peering at her recorder. “Oh, look at that! The crystals all burned out!”

That wasn’t a surprise, seeing as the metal had melted. Catra walked over to the others. “So, what does that mean?” she asked.

“Other than we should have some remedial ‘don’t trigger alien devices without checking first’ lessons?” O’Neill added.

That earned him a glare from Sam, Catra noted with some amusement. Not a big glare, though - if the device had blown up instead of melting, things could have been rather bad, even with She-Ra around and ready to restore the planet’s magic for an extra boost in power.

Entrapta, on the other hand, nodded, eyes glued to her tools. “It looks like the crystals served not only as a calibrating device but also to supply the antenna with power. The crystals’ structural integrity was used up for that - almost like splitting atoms, but with quite a bit less power, of course, since we’re still alive and not vaporised.”

Now that sounded concerning. “What about radiation?” Catra asked.

“Radiation? Oh, there was tons of that! And focused through the antenna!” Entrapta beamed.

“It wasn’t harmful radiation,” Sam quickly added. “The bright light was the only part of it that actually reached us.”

“Yes! The rest all went into a faster-than-light impulse. Like a one-time-use relay!” Entrapta explained.

“Or an alert,” O’Neill said with a grim expression.

“Or an alert,” Entrapta agreed. “Primed for a specific hyperspace frequency. Or for a set of hyperspace frequencies, to be more precise - there was some variation.”

An FtL alert beacon. Catra snorted. “So, we might get visitors as soon as they notice the alert. Visitors who might use the Stargate to check up on the planet.”

“Yes. Unless we secure the Stargate for transport before that,” Sam said.

Catra mentally calculated the distance to the Stargate. It wasn’t too far, but running all the way... “We better call the shuttle to pick us up.” That would be faster than running back. Even with the autopilot.

“Yes,” O’Neill agreed. “I already did my PT for the week.”

“You did?” Daniel asked. “Oh.”

Catra snorted as Bow called the shuttle, and Entrapta and Sam gathered the remains of the device.

A few minutes later, they were taking off again - just in time to see the Stargate activate and the vortex form. Bow brought the stealth shuttle to a stop at once. “Activating stealth system!” he announced.

That would keep them from being spotted but wouldn’t do anything about the regular transport shuttle waiting near the Stargate.

Before they could order the shuttle to take off, someone stepped through the gate. No, something floated through the gate.

“Oh! It’s an alien bot!” Entrapta beamed at the screen, her hair touching several buttons to zoom in.

The thing was about the size of a human torso. Entrapta was correct - it was a dull grey, with manipulator arms that almost reached the ground, a couple of what were probably sensors mounted in a band around its ‘head’ and what looked like a weapon in its rear. Catra had never seen it before, but it looked a little familiar. She had seen that style before…

“The Asgard?” Daniel asked.

“The technology and design don’t perfectly match what we observed from them,” Entrapta said, “but there are similarities that our scanner picked up.”

“Some of them quite distinct from the Horde technology that was a derivate of Asgard technology, but consistent with the expected variation from a similar base,” Sam added. “I agree - this is probably Asgard technology.”

“Well, let’s go say hello, then,” O’Neill commented. “Before the thing takes our transport apart trying to find out what happened.”

As Catra could see, the bot was already floating towards the parked shuttle. “Better hurry, Bow,” she said.

*****

The Scientist Part 1

PZ-825, January 30th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill was the first out of the shuttle, jumping off the ramp before it touched the ground. Catra would have been faster, but he had had a headstart and had blocked her from slipping past him when he hit the button to lower the ramp. Score one for age and experience.

But she landed - on all fours - a second after he had. "Cheater."

"Catra!"

And here came Adora, also jumping off the ramp - which touched down a moment later.

But Jack was focused on the bot turning to face them. He still couldn't see any similarity to Asgard designs. No runes, no stone-like look, just smooth, grey metal.

Then again, if Jack was setting up some covert alert systems, he wouldn't use bots with the US flag on them. He would use bots that looked like Goa'uld tech instead, of course. Confusion to the enemy, and all that.

Which raised the question if the style of this bot was aping someone else's. Well, they might find out. Jack smiled as he took a step forward - to the edge of the shuttle's shield. Just in case the bot wasn't from the Asgard. Or the bot was from some Asgard who had something to hide and no qualms about getting rid of witnesses. It would be stupid, of course, with all the sensors trained on them and the ships in orbit, but that never stopped some people.

"Hello!" Adora smiled at the drone. "I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. Who are you?"

Jack forced himself to keep smiling. It wasn't as if the bot hadn't already seen the Horde shuttle, and SG-1 was in uniform, with the US flag on the sleeve, but it still went against his instincts to present yourself like that on a covert mission. But the Etherians were in charge of diplomacy. And everything else, if it came down to that.

The bot didn't react for a moment, then slowly floated closer to Adora - though it stopped before touching the shield. "Did you trigger a hyperspace wave on the planet?" It added some technical blah-blah that didn't mean a thing to Jack - or to Adora, he could tell from her expression - but Carter, Entrapta and Bow, who were on the ramp behind them, started whispering.

"Maybe?" Adora tilted her head sideways as she smiled apologetically. "I'm not sure if…"

"Yes, we did!" Entrapta interrupted her. "If we interpreted your numbers correctly, then yes. Are you worried about your hyperspace detector beacon?"

"You found it?"

"It's considered rude in our culture not to introduce yourself if others did so," Jack cut in, resisting the temptation to imitate Daniel's way of speaking. "So, who're you?"

The bot tilted to face him - well, if you could call turning a band of blinking lights towards him that. Jack smiled widely at him. He could be diplomatic.

"You've had contact with us before."

"If you are who we think you are," Jack replied.

Another pause. "We are the Asgard, yes."

"Yes! I knew it!" Entrapta cheered behind him. "The technology matched!"

“It shouldn’t have been a clear match,” the bot retorted. “I did not use standard parts.”

“Welll… it wasn’t a perfect match. But there were enough similarities to tell the base from which you developed this,” Entrapta told the bot.

“You managed to derive the base technology from this? Of course, you had an example - or multiple examples to study, which must have helped your deductions.”

“You still haven’t told us your name,” Jack reminded the alien before the whole discussion could turn into technobabble.

“Ah. This is… a delicate matter.”

Delicate? Jack frowned. That sounded evasive. And the alien had been trying to hide their technology. Coupled with the whole hidden sensor… Jack grinned. “You’re not supposed to be here, are you?”

The bot didn’t react, but, once again, a moment passed before it replied: “You are as perceptive as your file claims, Colonel.”

Bingo! Jack nodded. “I try my best.”

Catra snorted.

“So, you don’t want to give us your name because you’re… breaking a law?” Adora asked.

“Not exactly. It would be more precise to say that I disagree with the interpretation of certain of our policies.”

“Yep, you’re breaking the law,” Catra commented.

“And this isn’t one of the protected planets,” Glimmer added. “So, what are you doing here?”

“You’re looking for something. Something that uses the hyperspace frequency we used to trigger your detector,” Entrapta said. “It’s not a common frequency amongst the other species we know. So…” She beamed at him. “...it’s a new species using that! And if you’re looking for them using this, we can do the same!”

“No, you can’t!” This time, the bot jerked.

Jack had a bad feeling about this.

*****

Adora blinked. The voice sounded agitated. This must be important.

Entrapta, though, shook her head. “I think we can - we can duplicate your sensors. Though we don’t need to; we can just calibrate our own to look for such signals. Or send such signals to see if they notice - as we demonstrated. If we spread out, we should increase our chances to contact this new species!”

“No! You can’t! They’re dangerous!” the voice yelled.

Entrapta cocked her head. “Dangerous? How?”

She sounded more interested than impressed or even afraid, Adora noted.

It took a second for the voice to answer. “They are an existential threat to every species in the galaxy.”

“That sounds as if you know them very well,” Jack commented in a casual tone. His eyes, though, had narrowed, Adora noticed.

“We do. I do.”

“And yet, you’re looking for them using hidden sensors. Hidden sensors that burn out after use. And you use a bot that is supposed to not look like it was built by you.” Jack tilted his head a bit to the side. “Something doesn’t add up.”

“When we met Thor, he claimed that all known existential threats to the galaxy were contained,” Catra said. Her tail was swishing back and forth, betraying her tension. “Why would you look for such a threat if it was contained?”

“And why wouldn’t the Asgard inform us if there was a new existential threat - or an older threat that broke containment?” Glimmer was frowning. “You know we have advanced technology and magic; if you need help, we’d be the obvious people to ask. Especially if this is a threat to us all.”

“On the other hand, not informing us of an existential threat would be kind of… not nice,” Jack added.

“Those are logical deductions,” the voice answered.

“You still haven’t told us who you are. I think we should ask Thor about this,” Catra said, making a point of studying her claws.

“I am Loki.”

“The trickster god of the Norse pantheon?” Daniel perked up. “There are many myths about you on Earth!”

“I know.”

“I’m not an expert on ancient myths, but ‘trickster god’ doesn’t really sound trustworthy,” Jack commented.

“Well, we don’t have many primary sources about Loki,” Daniel said. “Much of what we know was recorded centuries after the Christianisation of the Norse. And such myths and legends tend to be biased depending on who wrote them down. There are parallels to Greek gods in some tales, which might have been added at a later date, for example, but also might be tied to a myth shared by both cultures - there are several legends that appear, in similar form, amongst different cultures. For example…”

“I think we got the gist,” Jack cut him off. “So, Loki… care to share what you know about this ‘existential threat’? It sounds kind of

like we should know about this. And if you don't tell us, we probably have to investigate this, as Entrapta lined out."

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta beamed. "Can we?"

"And can we meet?" Adora asked. "It's better to talk face to face." Talking to a faceless bot wasn't how you were supposed to do diplomacy. Unless it was with a civilisation of faceless bots, of course. If such a thing existed.

Another moment passed. Then Adora heard a sigh, followed by Loki's voice. "I will travel through the gate to meet you."

"Thank you!" She smiled at the bot.

It took less than a minute, and an Asgard stepped through the Stargate. He was the same size as Thor and looked the same as well. They might be related. Although… the Asgard used clone bodies. Maybe they all looked the same?

"I guess clothing is optional for advanced species," Adora heard Jack mutter under his breath.

"I think that might just be the cultural norm for the Asgard," Daniel said. "They seem to eschew clothes, though it remains to be seen if that extends to belts and other pieces meant to carry tools. It might be a cultural taboo to wear anything, which would have shaped their customs and beliefs."

"Let's wait with analysing the Asgard until we have discussed the existential threat to the galaxy," Jack told him.

"Sorry."

"It's mostly that we don't need clothes, so we don't use them," Loki said as he reached them.

He must have good ears… no, his bot was still next to them, Adora realised. He would have overheard them talking through it.

“Ah.” Daniel nodded, then smiled at Jack.

Adora cleared her throat. “Hello, Loki. You already know me. These are my friends, Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, Princess Entrapta of Dryl…”

“I am familiar with your names,” Loki interrupted her. “And the stories of my deeds were, no doubt, warped in the centuries since our departure from Earth.”

“Of course you’d say that,” Catra muttered with a toothy grin.

“Oh? If we could check our myths against the events from which they originated, this would offer great insight into our understanding of other myths,” Daniel said.

“Daniel…” Jack hissed. “Existential threat now, dusty history later!”

“Sorry.”

“So, what is this existential threat you are so concerned about?” Adora asked.

“The Replicators.”

*****

“The Replicators?” Samantha Carter and Entrapta said in unison.

“They are self-replicating machines that consume everything in their path as they aggressively expand - or attempt to,“ Loki explained.

Sam’s eyes widened. A von Neumann swarm?

“Oh!” Entrapta nodded. “That’s what you warned me of, right, Sam? When we were designing our spy bot network.”

Sam suppressed a wince. Yes, the topic had come up. But this wasn’t the best moment to mention that.

“You planned to create self-replicating machines?” Loki… didn’t seem to be as shocked as Sam had expected. She could be mistaken, of course, since he was an alien, but it was something to think about. Later, though.

She ignored the look the Colonel gave her and shook her head. “It was a risk we had to consider when planning our automated recon network. A risk we avoided.”

“Well, technically, since we have automated factories producing spy bots, we did create self-replicating machines,” Entrapta said. “It depends on how strict you are with your definitions.”

“Machines that do not have the autonomy to act on their own,” Sam quickly added. “It’s just automated factories producing automated space probes.”

“Yes,” Entrapta nodded. “We didn’t make them smart, so they can’t expand their parameters and learn new things. Which makes them a bit less efficient than they could be. We have to manually adjust their parameters and orders.”

“I see.” Loki nodded. “Yes, the reason the Replicators are such a threat is their intelligence. They form a hive mind and so are able to adapt to various circumstances.”

“Such as people shooting at them?” the Colonel asked.

“The Asgards encountered the Replicators just when they were expanding past their system of origin. We have since then managed to contain them, although we were not yet able to eradicate them.”

“You contained them?” Sam asked. If such self-replicating machines had faster-than-light travel, all they had to do was to send small probes out to, well, everywhere, and start building up in secret. You couldn’t contain such a threat unless you could block them from travelling through hyperspace, and to interdict a ship or probe from entering hyperspace would require them to… “How do you keep them from entering hyperspace with their

probes?" You could disrupt hyperspace communications - suppress them, as the Alliance had done to the Goa'uld so far, which might be adapted to block travel as well. But that only worked for a short time and within a small range. Sooner or later, a determined enemy would manage to bypass such jamming during an engagement or escape the range of the jamming.

"If you're jamming hem, with enough power to disrupt travel, and within an entire system - or more - then that would require a lot of ships," Entrapta added. "And a lot of power, but if you just used more power, we should have noticed something since that would start to affect travelling through hyperspace in the entire sector. Well, only a tiny bit, but it should still be noticeable with precise sensors. Or when your calculations are just a tiny bit off."

Loki hesitated for a moment. Sam couldn't read him. "The Replicators need constant and uninterrupted communication through hyperspace to form their hive mind. If this is disrupted, they focus on restoring a connection to the exclusion of everything else. They also do not spread too far from each other, always staying within optimal communication range. It is unclear whether or not this is a technical limitation or merely a psychological one, as far as that is possible for machines, but it has allowed us to contain their expansion, albeit with great effort."

Sam frowned at that. If the Asgard could do that to the Replicators, then they should be able to destroy them, not merely contain them. Coupled with their obvious disdain for the Goa'uld and the fact that they had been on Earth a thousand years ago… "How long has this conflict been going on?"

"Quite some time," Loki replied.

"That's vague," Entrapta pointed out.

"Yes, it is." Loki sounded amused, at least in Sam's impression.

Entrapta pouted at him. "Without exact data, we can't really help you."

“We don’t require help. Our projections show that the Replicator’s capacities are steadily deteriorating in the face of our attacks. We should be able to eradicate them in the future. Eventually.”

Sam reminded herself that the Asgard used cloned bodies to extend their lifespan. That would affect what they considered long-term planning compared to humans or Etherians. And yet… Loki might not be telling them the entire truth.

“So, you have things well in hand. That’s why you have been planting sensors on worlds to look for them, and why you were freaking out about the possibility of us stumbling on those Replicators.” The Colonel’s sarcasm was quite obvious, but Loki didn’t seem to react.

“Yes.” Once more, he nodded. But after a moment, he added: “The Replicators are able to adapt quite efficiently to changing circumstances if they are given the opportunity. We have to constantly adjust our technology and tactics to retain our advantage. Your presence, intended or not, would likely prove disruptive.”

“That still doesn’t explain why you’re placing sensors to look for them,” Catra said,

“We are winning the conflict,” Loki replied. “But there is a chance, not a very great chance, but one that cannot be ignored, that the Replicators, faced with certain defeat, will radically break with prior behaviour and send out probes far further than they used to.”

“Past your pickets.” Catra nodded. “And you’re preparing for that.”

Loki inclined his head. “I am testing a method to detect them without being noticed by other civilisations, such as the Goa’uld.”

She grinned. “But you’re also hiding from your own people, aren’t you?”

Loki wasn’t amused - Sam was sure this time.

*****

Catra smirked when Loki - if that was actually his name - twitched. She didn't trust him. The Asgard were fighting a bunch of bots that were an existential threat to the galaxy and so dangerous that any 'interference' by outsiders could spell disaster? That sounded far too convenient to be true. A perfect excuse to keep the guy's secret that couldn't be questioned. Except, of course, by asking Thor. It still could be true, though.

"The Asgard are sometimes a bit too conservative. When faced with an enemy like the Replicators, one must be ready to innovate, to act proactively. Merely reacting to the enemy's stratagems is not enough to ensure victory," Loki said, staring at her.

She grinned as she met his eyes. She had seen worse glares, far worse glares. "So, you're doing this behind the back of your people - against their orders and laws, hm?"

"There is no law against placing sensors on uninhabited planets. Sensors that cannot be traced back to my people."

Catra hadn't much experience with the Asgard, but Loki sounded a bit smug here. He had that air of being too clever for his own good. And it was another evasive answer.

"Sure, that works - until you send in a bot that does point at your people," O'Neill said.

"That was in response to picking up a signal that seemed to be originating from the Replicators," Loki told him with a frown. "If Replicators had been present, then it would have been obvious to the High Council that my actions were justified."

"And you would have been vindicated," Glimmer said, slowly nodding.

Catra suppressed a snort. According to what she had heard, Glimmer would be very familiar with that situation. She must have

argued like that with her mother a lot. Her mother, who was… Catra pushed the thought and the guilt away. This wasn't the time.

"Yes." Loki nodded firmly.

Catra cocked her head to the side. The way he acted… "This isn't the first time you went against your people's laws."

Loki looked at her again. "I have had disagreements with the High Council in the past."

Catra was sure he had. He sounded very much like a 'the ends justify the means' guy. Not that there was anything wrong with that in principle. But he also struck her as a guy who thought he knew best.

"So, why shouldn't we call our buddy Thor and check your claims?" O'Neill asked. "We've got their number, and informing them of a potential crime would be the neighbourly thing to do."

"It would endanger my project, which could be all that stands between the galaxy and the Replicators," Loki said.

"Oh?" O'Neill faked surprise. "I thought the Asgard had the situation under control."

"All information indicates that this is correct, but there remains some uncertainty. So, a contingency is needed," Loki said.

"So, you have been placing such sensors on empty planets as a contingency?" Entrapta asked.

"Yes."

"How are you doing that?" She looked puzzled, Catra noticed. "According to the logs of the Stargate here, It took you an hour to install the sensors. If you want to cover a decent part of the sector, much less the galaxy, you would have to have a huge, really huge number of bots to place such sensors. And you're

limited to worlds with Stargates, which means your sensor coverage will have blind spots. Lots of them. We went over that when we planned our own network, and we could limit it to the Goa'uld Empire - you need to cover everything."

And it would take a massive amount of resources. Even if Loki had access to the resources of the Asgard, he wouldn't get them, Catra was sure. Because if those efforts went into the war instead, it might be won more easily. Loki might be arrogant, but was he such a fool?

"It is a start."

Catra narrowed her eyes. He wasn't acting as if he had just discovered a flaw in his plan. And he wasn't acting all smug and claiming he had solved this. He was hiding something. Something that made his actions make sense. Somehow. Oh. "You think you know where they'll be going, should they manage to break your people's blockade."

He tensed for a moment. Then he relaxed a bit too much. "I have made estimates based on their past behaviour."

"Oh?" Entrapta blinked. "You mean they have broken out before?"

"There were localised outbreak attempts that were stopped. The Replicators' need for constant communication limits them."

"But that would mean that this system is close to their system of origin," Sam said. "We've mapped this region thoroughly with our own probes and haven't found any sign of those Replicators or the Asgard."

"It isn't close, but I have reasons to suspect that this is the most likely vector for their expansion, should they achieve a breakthrough or overcome their limitations."

"Can we see your data?" Entrapta asked. "This sounds like an impressive deduction. It would also be helpful if we knew those limits in case we met those Replicators."

“Unfortunately, I can’t share the data. It’s too sensitive to be handed over to outsiders.”

“Oh?” O’Neill raised his eyebrows. “But you got access?”

“I have my means, but I can’t share the data with outsiders. That is something my people wouldn’t easily forgive.”

Catra clenched her teeth. Hearing these evasive answers, that smug undertone… Shadow Weaver had loved such games as well. And she hadn’t been trustworthy either. This whole thing still didn’t make much sense. Even if Loki had stolen the data, if he could predict the replicator’s actions, he should already be able to impress their High Council enough to make them overlook that. Results got you promotions and forgiveness. Catra knew how that worked from the Horde. Of course, it could be abused, but… Oh. That would be one way to ensure he got results. And praise. And power.

She narrowed her eyes. “You aren’t planning to plant some Replicators in the area for you to discover, are you?”

Loki twitched again.

*****

What? Jack O’Neill narrowed his eyes. That was a far-fetching question - accusation - but the way the alien twitched, Catra might be right on the nose. And it made sense. In a messed-up, stupid way. Time to double down on it. “You know that your enemies will appear here because you will plant them here. So you can play the hero,” he said.

The alien stared at Catra, then at him. And didn’t reply yet. Wasn’t Loki supposed to be smoother than that? Well, the Marvel comics were probably not a good resource about aliens playing gods. Though Jack filed the thought away. It would rile up Daniel quite nicely on a slow day.

“What?” Adora blurted out, belatedly. “You said that the Replicators were so dangerous, we couldn’t meet them for fear of disrupting your containment, but you plan to release them yourself?”

“Are you mad?” Glimmer added. The queen looked as if she was about to brain Loki with her staff. Well, Jack wouldn’t mind braining the alien himself.

“I am not mad!” Loki retorted, looking angry. “I have things prepared and under control! And even if a risk remained, it would be worth it!”

“It would be worth it? What do you expect to gain from this?” Glimmer asked. “Fame? Power?”

Once more, Loki hesitated.

“Probably both,” Jack said. On Earth, one thing tended to come with the other if you wanted both. But things might be different with the grey aliens.

Loki shook his head. “I do not desire power for power’s sake - but I need it to save my people.”

“You need to save your people?” Jack had heard that before. “From what? You said they had the situation with those ‘replicators’ in hand.” Of course, Loki had said a lot, and none of it could be trusted.

“Yes, the situation with the Replicators is under control. They are still dangerous, but we have been steadily pushing them back, and I do not foresee a reverse of that.”

“What about all the talk about them adapting and advancing?” Catra asked.

“Their theoretical potential is limited in practice by their need for advanced communication, massive power generation and the resources to provide both. And we have been attacking those

weaknesses. It's a war of attrition, and by my calculations, we have reached a tipping point already."

Jack wasn't quite sure if he would trust Loki's calculations. "So, what's that other existential threat that you need power to deal with? And why does it have to be you?" Making up a huge threat from which only you could save your people was a basic tactic to take over a country. But it seemed that, for all the stuff about the situation being under control - and Jack had heard that far too often right before something went majorly wrong to trust it - the Asgard already had such a threat.

Loki stared at him without saying anything. Time to increase the pressure, then - Jack was tired of the alien's attitude.

"We can always ask Thor," Catra stole Jack's line before he could say it.

Loki frowned at her.

Jack grinned. The alien probably regretted showing up. But them's the breaks when you try to pull off a plot like his.

Adora, though, smiled at Loki. "If you are in danger and need help, we'll help you, of course! But we can't help you if we don't know what you need. So, please, tell us what your problem is." She blinked. "That came out wrong. I mean, the threat to your people, not… uh…"

Catra snickered, and Jack had to grin himself. "Your attitude?" he suggested.

"Jack!" Daniel hissed behind him.

"Yes," Entrapta chimed in. "We can help you! I think we can, at least. But we'll try our best to help you, anyway."

"You already let slip that your people are facing a huge threat, so that secret's out already," Catra added. "Just tell us."

That was obviously not true. Revealing a potentially huge vulnerability was still a massive breach of security. Or would be on Earth. Not that Jack would say so, of course.

Loki looked from Adora to Entrapta, then to the rest of their group. Then he seemed to… not quite deflate, but hunch over a little. "This is not going as I planned."

"That's life," Jack told him. "You either adapt or die."

To his slight surprise, Loki chuckled at that. "That is actually an apt description of the problem, Colonel O'Neill."

"Oh?" Jack blinked. It had just been a platitude.

"As you know from Thor, the Asgard use cloned bodies to transfer our minds, our consciousnesses, into."

Oh, damn. Jack knew that tone - a lecture was incoming.

Of course, some of the others ate it up. Daniel looked as if he was going to take notes, and Entrapta…

"Yes!" She nodded several times with a wide smile. "An ingenious use of cloning and mind-reading technology! You could theoretically live forever that way! And if you use braindead clones, you're not hurting anyone, unlike Horde Prime."

Loki twitched again, Jack noted. But the alien quickly recovered. "There are a few drawbacks we discovered after the fact," he said. "We lost the ability to sexually reproduce. And… the cloning method was not quite as perfect as we thought."

They didn't have sex any more? Wait, Loki said reproduction. No need to feel sorry for them, then.

"Oh." Entrapta cocked her head. "You had cloning errors?"

"Over time, our genome degraded. We realised it too late to easily fix it," Loki explained. "If we cannot halt and reverse the process,

we are facing extinction."

"You want to fix your genome?" Entrapta asked. "That shouldn't be too hard. I mean, you created Horde Prime, didn't you? And his cloning technology is impressive! Or was that your technology?"

"'Horde Prime' was an attempt to fix our genome. An attempt that was… less than successful." Loki scowled. "The changes were far more extensive than projected, especially in the psyche. He was meant to be an Asgard, not… whatever he turned out to be in the end."

"You mean when he ran away?" Daniel asked.

"Yes." Loki nodded. "But he showed me that there was a way to adapt our cloning process and, if not restore our genome, force it into a viable state again, close enough to what we were so we would still be Asgard and not something too different."

"Yes." Entrapta nodded with a smile. "If your experiment fails, you try again until it works. That's how science works!"

"Exactly! I just needed a few more experiments!" Loki smiled at her. "But the High Council forbade me from further refining my research. And without their authorisation, I cannot access the data I need for my research!"

"What resources do you need?" Carter asked. "Your 'experiment' here must have taken significant resources as well."

"That only took time and some material resources. But I need access to our restricted databanks so I can work with the last archived semi-viable genome data. I tried using my own genetic data, but as Horde Prime showed, that was not enough."

Ah. "And as the hero who prevented the Replicators from spreading across the Galaxy when everyone else missed them, you could get that access." Jack nodded. That explained it.

“Yes!” Loki nodded sharply. “Do you now see why this is necessary?”

“Sort of.” Jack wasn’t sure granting a mad scientist access to such data was a good idea at all. “But…”

“Wait!” Entrapta blurted out, interrupting him. And she beamed at Loki as if he had just told her she could have an unlimited research budget and tiny food forever or something. “You used your genes to create Horde Prime? That means you’re Hordak’s grandfather! You’re family!”

Oh, damn… Jack clenched his teeth together so he wouldn’t curse out loud.

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Oh! Adora gasped. She hadn’t considered that - and she should have! She had known that Horde Prime was a clone of the Asgard, ever since their meeting on Cimmeria, but she should have realised what that meant. He had a family! All the clones had a family! Not just people related to him, but their actual grandfather! Or grandmother, or however that was supposed to work with clones. Of clones. And clones of clones of clones.

This was a little confusing.

Loki looked… well, a little shocked. “That’s not how the Asgard see it,” he said. “We have stopped sexually reproducing.”

“But if you used your own genetic material to create new life, that would be your offspring. Biologically, at least,” Daniel spoke up.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “And you created your clone deliberately - in an attempt to solve your species’ problem. So, Horde Prime was supposed to be an Asgard, you said that yourself. And his clones share enough of your DNA that your own systems on Cimmeria considered them Asgard. Kinda, at least.” She nodded. “So, they are your children. Yours, as in you, not your people.”

Loki stared at her, his mouth opening, then closing, before he shook his head. “That is not how it works for the Asgard.”

“Well, I’m not sure that argument would fly in a family court on Earth,” Jack added with a smirk. “If all the clones want child support…” he whistled. “That could be quite expensive.”

“What?” Loki looked confused.

“Ah, Jack is, ah, joking - I doubt that a court on Earth would have jurisdiction, although if a clone became a citizen of a country on Earth…” Daniel shook his head. “Anyway, I do not think a parent - or grandparent in this case - would owe anyone child support since the clones are adults and employed. Although, technically, and biologically, I guess, some of them are very young.”

“Yes! WrongHordak is a few years old - we were there when he was released from the cloning pod!” Entrapta nodded.

“But I don’t think we can just project our own cultural norms on the Clones or the Asgard,” Daniel retorted. “Our histories and societies are far too different.”

“Yes. We have abandoned sexual reproduction,” Loki said.

“But did you abandon any reproduction?” Sam asked. “You said you transfer your consciousnesses into braindead clones. But do you also, ah, grow clones with brains to raise them as new individuals?”

“With our genetic degradation, such reproduction has been put on hold. It was deemed unethical to create a new individual under such circumstances.”

Adora blinked. That sounded…

“Was that before or after you created Horde Prime?” Glimmer asked.

“Long before that, fewer and fewer Asgard had opted to raise offspring,” Loki replied.

“So, the answer is ‘Yes’.” Jack snorted.

“It was a short-sighted decision.” Loki seemed to pout. “Even with our current problems, creating new individuals is a necessity. They would not be worse off than existing Asgard. And they would serve to alleviate some of the constraints caused by our war against the Replicators.”

“You said the war was as good as won,” Adora pointed out. “Why would there be such ‘constraints’?”

“I said that the war will be won, although it will still require considerable effort,” Loki corrected her.

“Well, fighting a war while you don’t reproduce seems a little short-sighted,” Jack commented. “People tend to die in wars.”

“Exactly!” Loki nodded at him. “We can’t afford to lose more individuals. Especially not those with a vast range of experience and talent.”

Adora blinked. That was… “You wanted clones to use in the war? Was that why Horde Prime deserted you?”

Loki glanced at her. “Every Asgard is expected to fight the Replicators if they’re needed.”

“So, Horde Prime was supposed to be an Asgard!” Entrapta nodded. “He was your child then!”

“He was not an Asgard!” Loki snapped.

Entrapta shook her head. “His DNA was close enough! So, technically, all the Clones should be Asgard! You all are clones anyway!”

“I don’t think that’s how it works,” Daniel said. “There are obvious differences between, ah, Horde Clones and the Asgard.”

“Superficial Ones!” Entrapta retorted. “Who cares about different exteriors? The DNA matters!”

Jack grimaced, Adora noticed. Entrapta was a bit too dismissive. This was a delicate subject, after all. Adora knew that - she was a First One, but she had been raised in the Horde. Hordak’s Horde. Was she a First One or not? She straightened. This wasn’t about her. “I think that’s not something anyone of us can decide. Not even you, Loki. Not without asking the clones what they think.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “We have to tell them that their grandfather is here!”

That wasn’t exactly what Adora had meant or how she would put it. But it was close enough.

She nodded and took out her communicator. Then she froze for a moment. The highest ranking Clone present was Priest…

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“So you are the father of the Great Deceiver. He who wanted to rule the universe’s ashes but was brought to justice by Her divine grace, the holy She-Ra, Princess of Power, hallowed be Her name!”

Priest seemed to be expanding his vocabulary. Or at least varying his sermons - Samantha Carter wasn’t quite sure if she had heard those titles before, though she didn’t make a habit of following the Church of She-Ra. It was better for her peace of mind. And she was a scientist, not a theologian.

“You claim to be a goddess?” Loki stared at Adora, but Sam couldn’t tell if he was outraged or surprised. The Asgard despised the Goa’uld, after all, and this would likely include their practices of deceiving their followers into worshipping them.

“I am not a goddess!” Adora protested, blushing.

“Your deeds prove Your divinity, Your Divine Highness, for you have saved us all from being enslaved by the Great Deceiver! Evidence of Your miracles is everywhere to be found!”

Sam suppressed a shiver at the rapt expression on Priest’s face. This kind of fanaticism was dangerous - and the way he kept insisting that She-Ra was a goddess, despite her open denial, was almost delusional.

“You revere her as a goddess against her will?” Loki seemed surprised now. “Despite her clearly denying it?”

“As Her divine wisdom teaches us, your deeds, not your words, define you. And Her deeds are, undoubtedly, those of a goddess,” Priest retorted. “Her Divine Highness has wrought multiple miracles by any definition found on both Etheria and Earth. She has turned the Great Deceiver’s base from a weapon into a monument of peace, transforming dead metal and advanced composite into a living plant that thrives even in the cold vacuum of space. She has healed the sick and raised the dead, saved countless worlds from destruction and returned Etheria from the dimension in which it was trapped to this universe, restoring the very stars to the sky and magic to the galaxy!”

Loki blinked, then stared at Adora. “Is this true?”

“It’s… technically, it’s…” Adora shook her head. “It’s not like that!”

“You can transform metal into living matter and move worlds between dimensions?”

“That was a special occasion where all the magic that the First Ones had taken from the galaxy was released, and I had to channel it into something!”

Sam winced at that. Adora might try to downplay what she had done, but this was making things worse. Priest was beaming at her, and Loki… looked sceptical.

“I see,” he said.

“You do?” Adora smiled at him. “I am no goddess!”

“Many tales speak of gods walking the earth in mortal form,” Priest said. “And gods often test the faith of their followers. But we shall not fail You, Your Divine Highness! Your divine wisdom shows us the way! As You have freed the slaves and protected the weak, and are tirelessly working to expunge evil wherever You find it, so shall we, following your example!”

“Ah…” Adora trailed off, obviously at a loss for words.

Sam was sympathetic. Those were noble goals, after all. But who knew how Priest would define what was good and just in the future? He was clearly willing to ignore Adora’s words when it suited him. Not quite unlike certain priests ignored the Bible when it suited them.

“I don’t quite understand this,” Loki said.

“OK! Hordak’s coming!” Entrapta interrupted before Adora - or Priest - could reply to the Asgard. “WrongHordak as well!”

The Stargate through which she had been communicating with Etheria deactivated. A few seconds later, it activated again, establishing a connection from Etheria.

And Hordak stepped through, followed by another clone. WrongHordak.

“Loki, these are Hordak and WrongHordak, two more of your grandchildren!” Entapta beamed to Loki. “Hordak, WrongHordak, this is Loki! He created Horde Prime from his own genetic material!”

Both clones looked at the Asgard. After a moment, Hordak spoke.

“Why?”

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The Scientist Part 2

PZ-825, January 30th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Why?" Catra watched as Loki repeated Hordak's question, tilting his head at him.

"Why did you create Horde Prime?" Hordak explained.

"As I already explained, and as you were undoubtedly told, I wanted to save my species and create a variant that was not suffering from genome degradation, yet close enough to be an Asgard." Loki stood a bit straighter.

"I know your goals," Hordak told him in a tight tone. Catra was reminded of a few rather tense meetings with him. "I want to know why it went wrong and you created that monster."

"That's a question I've been asking myself."

Loki was deflecting again. Catra hated it.

"And what answer did you find?" WrongHordak asked. He looked tense as well, which was a new look for him.

"My research remained inconclusive," Loki replied. "I was denied the means to test if it was a question of nature over nurture."

Catra blinked. Nature over nurture? She had heard about that question, but what…?

"You were planning to repeat your… 'experiment'?" Daniel blurted out.

"That is how a scientist researches," Loki told him, sounding puzzled. "You experiment and vary the parameters to find out which ones caused a given result."

“You wanted to create more children as *an experiment*?” Bow asked. He sounded shocked.

Catra glanced at Entrapta. Her friend was blinking, looking puzzled. But before Catra could get worried, Entrapta shook her head. “You don’t experiment with people! Not like that, at least. You can experiment with them if they volunteer to be your test subjects and your experiment doesn’t hurt them. Or not much - the material I read about that was a little inconclusive in that regard.” She pouted for a moment, then nodded. “But everyone agreed that creating children for experiments is wrong.”

Hordak, too, was looking at her. Momentarily distracted, it seemed.

Not so WrongHordak. “You wanted to create more Horde Primes? To see where you went wrong?”

“Yes, exactly,” Loki replied. “I needed to know how to prevent another result like the first. If I had erred in raising the subject, then that should have been easily fixable. But if the problem was the genes themselves, then that would have been more complicated because the Asgard’s genome needs more variation to become and stay viable, so I would have to find a way to avoid unwanted results.”

“I can see where you don’t want more genocidal tyrants trying to conquer the galaxy with their horde of mind-controlled clones,” O’Neill drawled.

“Yes, exactly.” Loki beamed at him.

Catra wondered if he was faking it or honestly didn’t get the sarcasm.

“You would have risked unleashing more such evil on the galaxy?” Priest sounded aghast.

“Of course not!” Loki shook his head. “I would have limited their lifespans so this would not have been an issue.”

Catra blinked. He couldn't mean… that was…

"You would have engineered your children to die before they could grow up?" Bow gasped.

Catra noticed she had unsheathed her claws without realising it. This was… monstrous.

"Not before they were grown up, of course - it would defeat the experiment's goals if they died while still in the cloning tubes," Loki retorted. "But they wouldn't need to live longer than necessary to determine their mental characteristics."

"That's horrible!" Glimmer spat.

"You can't do that!" Adora had drawn her sword, Catra saw, and was gripping it tightly.

And Hordak, WrongHordak and Priest were quickly following her example. "I think it's very clear which factor was responsible for Horde Prime's evil," Hordak said.

"Oh?" Loki actually sounded pleased. "You have found an answer?"

"It's *you*," Hordak spat. "I am very grateful that Horde Prime didn't pass your heritage on to us when he created us as his obedient servants."

Loki glanced at everyone. He seemed taken aback by all the hostility. Catra couldn't help wondering if he was like Entrapta, genuinely not understanding their reaction because he didn't know better, or if he was like Horde Prime, not caring about the reactions of anyone else until he was forced to. "That was a thousand years ago," Loki said after a moment. "Since then, I have changed my plans."

"Your goals remain the same, though," Catra said.

"Of course. I have to save my species."

He didn’t have to add ‘no matter the price’ - Catra could hear it clearly anyway.

And so could everyone else. Even Entrapta.

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Jack O’Neill could respect a man’s - alien’s - dedication to save their species from extinction. But there were a few lines you didn’t cross. Not even with your species’s survival on the line. Jack had done quite a few unsavoury things himself in his career, on orders, but making kids and raising them just to see what went wrong with the first one? And ensuring they wouldn’t live longer than necessary for the experiment? Jack had thought creating clones - kids - just to send them into war was horrible, but this was beyond the pale.

And Jack didn’t think the alien had actually changed. He wasn’t an expert on the Asgard. He wasn’t Daniel, either. But after more than twenty years in the Air Force, he could spot bullshit excuses, and Loki’s claim hit all the triggers.

“Uh,” Daniel spoke up. “Do the, ah, Horde clones suffer from the same genome degradation as the Asgard?”

“Horde Prime would have never accepted a vessel for his consciousness that was anything but perfect,” Hordak replied. “Any supposed flaws, especially fundamental ones, would have been eliminated.”

With extreme prejudice, as far as Jack understood.

“He never understood that imperfection is beautiful,” Entrapta said, nodding - and beaming at Hordak.

Jack suppressed a wince. That relationship still felt creepy to him, and it wasn’t because Hordak was an alien clone. But, ultimately, it was none of his business.

"And he had a problem with independent thought," Catra added. Adora wrapped an arm around her waist in response.

"And he was punished for his evil!" Priest spoke up. "As he spread pain and misery in his greed for power, even daring to try and turn Her chosen consort against her, Her Divine Highness smote him down and saved us all!"

Adora opened her mouth, probably to refute that, but Catra whispered something to her, and she relented.

Daniel looked a little uncomfortable but then pushed his glasses up and turned to look at Loki. "You mentioned that you wanted to create, ah, clones that were 'close enough to the Asgard'. Do you think Horde Prime and his clones do not qualify?"

Jack frowned - they looked completely different. The Asgard were small little grey aliens. Hordak and the other clones were tall, almost buff guys. And their heads and faces were different as well.

"It's obvious that they aren't Asgard," Loki replied with a frown.

"But their DNA is close - so close, even your own scanners think they're Asgard," Entrapta pointed out.

"That was the result of the scanners not being calibrated properly since their operators were not aware of the clones' existence," Loki retorted. "It has since then been fixed to eliminate such mistakes."

Now, *that* sounded familiar. "Can't have just anyone be Asgard, huh?" Jack said.

"Yes." Loki nodded. "Shared ancestry does not make us the same species."

"But they're your grandchildren! You created Horde Prime from your own DNA!" Entrapta protested.

“I don’t want to be related to either of them,” Hordak spat.

“But we are,” WrongHordak disagreed.

“And we should not attempt to disavow our origin!” Priest nodded emphatically. “For good and ill, the Great Deceiver shaped our history - as he was shaped before by the Reckless Scientist.”

Entrapta blinked, then perked up and nodded.

“Those who forget their past are doomed to repeat their mistakes,” Priest went on. “Only by remembering and acknowledging our origin can we move on, can we become better and make the universe better.”

Loki was still frowning. “You claim to be Asgard?”

“No!” Priest shook his head. “But we are your descendants. Yours specifically. Just as we are Horde Prime’s descendants.”

“Well, he called us his brothers, but we were his creation,” WrongHordak added. “So, it would be more correct to call us his children.”

Hordak muttered something that Jack didn’t quite catch. It didn’t sound complimentary, though.

“Children who have rejected their evil past and strive to make amends,” Priest said, folding his hands in a serene gesture. Some had been studying preachers on Earth. “As Her Divine Highness taught and showed us, it is never too late to abandon your path and redeem yourself.” He turned to look at his fellow clones. “We are living proof of that.”

Hordak grumbled in return, but WrongHordak nodded - and smiled at Loki. “Indeed.”

Jack grinned at the obvious message.

Loki frowned again. “If you are insinuating that I should abandon my plans to save my species, then I will tell you that I won’t. I will not see my species going extinct.”

“They aren’t disagreeing with your goals, merely with your methods,” Daniel said.

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “Priest is right - you are reckless. And the end doesn’t justify the means. Not your means.”

“That’s illogical. The survival of the species outweighs the survival of the individual,” Loki told her.

“You can justify everything with that!” Adora blurted out.

“Yes, exactly.” Loki nodded.

Adora blinked. “That’s not what I meant!”

Jack snorted, though it wasn’t funny. He was familiar with those types as well. Too familiar. Loki would have fit in perfectly with the NID. And with other, even worse, organisations.

*****

Adora shook her head. “You can’t justify everything with that!” Had Loki misunderstood her, or was he mocking her?

“The survival of my species is at stake,” he objected. “Would you sacrifice yours for the sake of a few individuals?”

Adora tensed. Did he know that she was a First One? “My species *is* extinct,” she told him with a glare. “They were fighting Horde Prime, and he killed them.”

Loki looked taken aback but quickly recovered. “Then you should understand my stance. You fought a war against Horde Prime, didn’t you? In a war, sometimes, you have to send soldiers to their deaths to win a battle.”

So, he knew about her history - Thor knew she was a First One, she remembered - but he didn't understand. Adora clenched her teeth. "My ancestors planned to sacrifice Etheria to win the war. They planned to destroy an entire world, with all the innocent people on it, to save themselves. My predecessor, Mara, prevented that - and she was a First One herself.."

Loki frowned. "So, she sacrificed her own species to save another? And you think that's acceptable, but sacrificing a few individuals isn't?"

He really didn't understand! "She sacrificed *herself*!" Adora spat. "And she didn't sacrifice her species - Horde Prime destroyed them. She didn't choose them to be destroyed. She saved Etheria from destruction at the hands of the First Ones, who were willing to kill everyone to save themselves. And that wasn't right. And isn't right."

"Indeed!" Priest nodded eagerly. "As Your Divine Highness's deeds have taught us, it is the duty of the strong to protect the weak and the innocent. Those who would sacrifice innocents to save themselves do not deserve to be saved in the first place."

That was… well, not wrong, but the way Priest said it sounded was a bit off.

"But what if they would have died anyway?" Loki obviously still didn't get it. "If you can save your species by sacrificing a few of them, then why would that be worse than letting everyone die? Isn't it better to save some rather than none? Wouldn't you sacrifice yourself to save others?"

"Yes, it is better to save some rather than none," Adora admitted. "But to harm innocents is wrong. Sacrificing yourself doesn't mean you're allowed to sacrifice others."

"Especially not children," Glimmer added. "Soldiers choose to fight, knowing that they might die. Children don't."

Jack coughed, but when Adora looked at him, he shook his head. "Nothing."

"He still thinks we were kids when we entered the war," Catra whispered next to her.

Oh. That was wrong. But they couldn't talk about that right now.

"In a war, the leaders sometimes have to make hard decisions. They have to decide whom to save and whom to let die," Loki said.

Catra scoffed. "Sending soldiers out to fight and die, picking a rearguard to stay and delay the enemy to save the rest, is not the same as *creating* children who will die soon after birth so you can experiment on them."

"I am not planning to do this any more," Loki replied.

Then why was he arguing?

"But is that because you realised that it was wrong or because you have discovered alternatives to your experiment?" Daniel asked. "And would you still pursue your original plan of action if the alternatives turned out to be nonviable?"

Loki tilted his head. "Even if that were the case, I wouldn't have to limit a clone's lifespan. Since you have managed to destroy Horde Prime, you could deal with any other clone that escaped and became a danger to the galaxy."

"What?"

"You want us to kill your clones?" Glimmer spat. "If they escape your control?"

Loki once again seemed confused. "If they become a danger to everyone else, yes. You stated that you would defend the innocent. If another clone decided to follow Horde Prime's

example, they would be a threat to many innocents, as Horde Prime has proven."

"That… that's not the point!" Adora clenched her teeth again.

"You can't just create clones and expect us to kill them if they go bad!" Bow blurted out.

"Why not? I do not understand why you would find it objectable that I would expect you to take the necessary steps to save the innocents when you have repeatedly stated that you would do that."

"If you're endangering everyone else by creating more genocidal space dictators, then the 'necessary steps' to save everyone would be to stop you before you create more clones," Jack commented. He looked very angry - well, he looked as if he was very angry but controlling himself.

"Like the High Council of the Asgard has done," Daniel added. "As you told us."

Loki seemed to pout.

"Besides, you don't need that anyway!" Entrpata said. "The Clones already prove that it's not the genes that make them evil."

"That has not been confirmed," Loki objected. "Horde Prime might have altered their genetic makeup."

Well, he had looked slightly different, with his four eyes and the tentacles, Adora had to admit. But that didn't matter! This wasn't about Horde Prime's actions but about Loki's!

"Well, that doesn't matter," Entrapta echoed her thoughts. "With all the data we have, it should be possible to do it right. I am sure Alpha will love to work on a challenging project again!"

Oh. Adora wasn't sure if that was a good idea.

*****

“Alpha?” Loki asked.

“Alpha is the bot running Research Station Alpha,” Entrapta answered. “The main research station for the First Ones experiments with genetic engineering.”

Samantha Carter took a step forward. She wasn’t an expert on alien biology and customs, but the way Loki’s eyes widened, she felt the need to be ready to block him from jumping Entrapta. Maybe literally.

Then she realised that Hordak had done the same on the other side.

“The First Ones? Do you mean the Ancients? You have access to one of their research stations for genetic engineering?” Loki asked, almost breathlessly.

“And one of their bots,” Entrapta confirmed before Sam thought of intervening. Her friend slipped between her and Hordak and beamed at Loki. “So, we should be able to solve your genetic problem! Although it might take a while - we have so many other projects to research in so many fields!”

“This takes priority!” Loki retorted, sounding agitated. “Nothing else is more important!”

“Unless you’re about to die out tomorrow, I would think the war against those robots is a bit more important,” the Colonel commented.

Loki shook his head. “The Replicators are contained and will be dealt with in the foreseeable future. Besides, my brother and his troops have the situation in hand.”

“Your brother? Thor, like in the myths, Supreme Commander of the Asgard?” Daniel asked.

“Yes, Thor. You’ve met him, haven’t you?” Loki tilted his head at Daniel. “While he is waging war, I am free to focus on saving our species.”

He sounds as fanatical as Priest, Sam thought. It was understandable, to a degree, if what he had told them about the Asgard’s problems with genome degradation was true, but it still made her wary.

“Research Station Alpha is of great importance to our people,” Glimmer said. “For several reasons. Allowing you access to it, much less to conduct genetic experiments there, is a delicate topic.”

“What?” Loki tensed again, staring at her. “Are you using it to research new weapons for your war against the Goa’uld? Maybe a virus that specifically targets Goa’uld?”

Sam clenched her teeth and took a slow breath. That this was his first guess said a lot about Loki.

“That would kill our friends as well,” Entrapta said with a frown.

“We’re not going to create, much less use, biological weapons,” Adora stated.

“Her Divine Highness has spoken about this before,” Priest added. “Such weapons kill indiscriminately, making no distinction between combatants and civilians. To use them goes against everything the Holy She-ra stands for.”

“It’s also a war crime,” the Colonel added. “In case you aren’t religious, you know.”

“If you’re not using it for weapon research, what are you using it for that would be more important than saving my entire species from extinction?” Loki ignored the Colonel and focused on Entrapta.

“Well… we’re planning to use it to solve the Jaffa’s problem with their immune system,” she replied.

“You are planning to use it?”

“We didn’t get around to start research yet.” Entrapta smiled apologetically, Sam saw. “We’ve got so much to do, and it’s apparently hard finding scientists who can do that kind of research.”

“I am a qualified geneticist,” Loki said at once. “In exchange for the opportunity to save my species, I would offer you my help in solving your problem.”

“Yeah… I don’t think we want to turn the Jaffa into genocidal conquerors. We already have the Goa’uld for that,” the Colonel said.

“Indeed.”

Glimmer stepped forward. “As I said, granting access to Research Station Alpha is a very delicate topic. There are important questions about security as well as politics to settle first.”

Such as the question of who actually had a claim to it, as Sam understood the matter. Alpha answered to Adora and the Colonel, as it considered them Ancients, but as Queen of Bright Moon, Glimmer laid claim to the First Moon of Enchantment, on which the base was located. But one could also - and more than a few did - argue that as the literal birthplace of Etheria’s population, the base belonged to the entire planet.

Whatever the answer, Sam was quite sure that letting Loki run wild in the base would be a terrible decision.

“What do you want? What is your desire?” Loki asked, fixating on Glimmer now. “I’ll do anything to save my species! Name your price!” He sounded almost desperate.

The Etherians looked taken aback. Adora bit her lower lip. "It's not about… we don't expect *payment*," she said. "And we will help you. We will save your species." She nodded. "But we can't just let you into the base. Not without, ah, organising things beforehand. And we have to talk to Alpha first. And the others who are involved." She glanced at the Colonel, Sam noted.

"Yeah. We haven't gotten around to straighten things out there yet," the Colonel said.

"But that shouldn't take long - we already need the base to save the Jaffa," Entrapta said, smiling widely. "And that's a priority since we can't let our prisoners die if they lose their larvae."

"I see." Loki slowly nodded, his eyes looking at her, then at the others in the room. "How long will that take?"

"We'll contact you in… a week," Glimmer said. "We should know more by then."

A stalling tactic. Sam was familiar with it. But what else could they say now?

Loki opened his mouth, then closed it again before nodding. "This is acceptable. I will be at the Stargate I use today in a week, then, to continue our discussion." He started to turn away.

"Not so fast!"

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Catra shook her head as Loki turned around. "We're not finished." She almost rolled her eyes at the surprised expression on some of her friends' faces. "We still need to talk about Horde Prime."

"He has been dealt with. By you," Loki replied. "What else is there left to discuss?"

This time, she rolled her eyes. "Apart from your relationship with the Horde?" She cocked her head and ignored the stare from

Glimmer; she might not have the family issues of others, but she could understand wanting to know about your origin. But that wasn't really her business. "We need to know how exactly an experimental clone of yours managed to run away and build an Empire that destroyed the First Ones and conquered a big chunk of the sector. Especially if you expect us to grant you access to First Ones technology."

She saw the others nod in agreement. "Yes," Entrapta said. "We need to know what happened so we can avoid a similar outcome."

And it would shed more light on how the Horde came to be. Though how the Clones would react to that… Hordak, at least, was scowling openly at Loki, while WrongHordak looked tense, and Priest was, as usual, trying to appear serene and not quite pulling it off.

Loki looked at her, then at Catra and the others. He didn't look at the Clones, she noticed. Then he seemed to sigh. "I thought I had succeeded when Horde Prime turned out to be viable. It hadn't been a perfect result, of course. The differences between his appearance and the Asgard's, even that of our far-distant ancestors before we started cloning, were quite striking, but the genetic makeup was close to what I envisioned back then. But appearance and genome were merely a part of the solution. Without advanced intelligence, the experiment would have been a failure. So, I taught and tested him."

That was… well, Loki still didn't seem to realise how he talked about his offspring. Like an experiment. Like a project.

Like Shadow Weaver had talked about her.

Catra had a feeling she could understand why Horde Prime had become what he had become. Understand but not excuse, of course.

"His metal facilities were superb," Loki went on. "He quickly mastered whatever I taught him, exceeding my expectations. And

he showed initiative, volunteering to assist me with my experiments. I thought it was an honest offer and foolishly accepted it."

"So, you taught him enough about your technology to allow him to study more by himself, then showed him how you created him?" Glimmer asked.

"Effectively, yes." Loki nodded. "And then he betrayed my trust, tried to kill me and ran away with my research ship," he added with a deep scowl.

"And he had everything he needed to start the Horde," Adora said.

"Let me guess: He had access to your notes." Catra shook her head.

"He would have hardly been able to assist me without access to those," Loki replied, "I trusted him with my research, and in return, he betrayed me!"

Me, me, me. Yeah, like Shadow Weaver. Catra clenched her teeth. Loki was all about himself. "And did those notes include your plans for failed experiments?" she asked.

She heard Adora draw a sharp breath, not quite a gasp - her lover understood what she was suspecting.

As did Loki. He scowled. "Of course. But why would that matter? Horde Prime showed no concern when we terminated other failed experiments while he assisted me. I had no reason to suspect he would betray me."

Catra gasped - and she wasn't the only one.

"You've actually killed your children?" Adora sounded shocked.

"I terminated experiments. Nonviable ones," Loki said.

“Define ‘nonviable’.” Hordak sounded utterly frigid. Back when she had been serving him in the Horde, Catra would have started to look for cover. And a scapegoat.

“Experiments that didn’t match the minimum parameters to be viable.”

Another evasive answer.

“Viable or valuable?” Hordak pressed on.

“Viable.” Loki tilted his head. “I would not waste resources raising clones to maturity that would not exceed my earlier results.”

So, no murder. That wasn’t as bad as Catra had feared - if Loki was telling the truth, of course.

Hordak inclined his head. “I see.” He was still scowling.

“So, you made it clear that you were working on creating clones that would surpass Horde Prime?” WrongHordak said. “With Horde Prime?”

Oh. Catra winced. How had she missed that? That alone would have been enough for Horde Prime’s ego to murder Loki since he had seen himself as the perfect being. At least the Horde Prime she had known. But they still didn’t know if he had been born that way or if being raised by Loki had formed him. Or a combination of both.

But they knew that Loki couldn’t be trusted with children. Or anyone else, actually.

“Yes?” Loki replied, tilting his head again. “I already said that.”

“You never raised a child before, did you?” Bow cut in.

“Asgard society is not focused on raising children.”

“That’s a yes,” O’Neill said.

“Well, it makes sense. If a species is using cloned bodies to extend their lives - infinitely, it seems - and not raising many children any more, then the experience necessary to raise children would become a specialised skill not available to the average member of the species. Perhaps there were specialists who would raise children, or anyone who wished to raise a child would have to earn special qualifications, which, of course, would cut down on the number of people having children,” Daniel said. “It’s quite a fascinating society.” He glanced at the others and winced. “Sorry.”

“So, your ignorance and arrogance planted the seed of your own failure,” Priest said, nodding. “You assumed you knew everything and did not need any help and treated your children as resources. The Great Deceiver truly was your son.”

Catra flashed her teeth at Loki’s expression.

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Yeah, Priest might be a dangerous fanatic, but he hit the nail on the head with that comment, in Jack O’Neil’s opinion.

“I think we know enough,” the third of the Clones, WrongHordak - and was a weird name, no matter what Daniel said about cultural differences and naming traditions - said. “Both about Horde Prime’s origin and our ancestor.”

Jack agreed. More than enough. The more Loki talked, the more Jack wanted to shoot him. And that would be undiplomatic and threaten or ruin their relations with the Asgard, such as there were. And probably murder, but Jack could live with the last. The way Loki spoke about his kids…

“Yes.” Hordak nodded sharply, still glaring at Loki.

“You do?” Entrapta sounded confused.

The former warlord’s expression softened when he turned his head to address her. It was still creepy. “We know enough to reject him as we rejected Horde Prime.”

“Oh.” Entrapta nodded slowly.

Jack wasn’t quite sure that she understood it. Well, Carter could explain it. Or Daniel, but Carter knew Entrapta better.

Loki himself cocked his head to the side again. “I am not like Horde Prime at all!” he said, sounding indignant. “Unlike him, I have never attempted to conquer the galaxy!”

“It’s not about politics,” Jack told him, baring his teeth. “It’s about your parenting.”

Loki blinked. “As far as I am aware, Horde Prime’s clones did not disobey him until he was defeated by She-Ra. Unlike Horde Prime.”

“I defied him before his defeat!” Hordak spat.

“And I fought to defend Etheria,” WrongHordak added. “Although, to be honest, these were special circumstances since my indoctrination was interrupted before it could take hold.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “That was us. We didn’t plan to, though - I thought you were Hordak at first, which is why I named you WrongHordak.”

“A name I’ve worn since then with pride and gratitude.”

Hordak, unsurprisingly, scoffed at that.

But that reminded Jack of something. “Speaking of names… I don’t think you named your son Horde Prime. Did you?”

“Of course not! That was a name he gave himself after he fled to build his Empire.” Loki sneered. “Why would I call him that?”

“It’s just…” Jack did his best Columbo impression. “You always called him ‘Horde Prime’ when you talked about him right now.”

Loki nodded. “That was what everyone else knew him as, and, therefore, the most logical designation to avoid confusion.”

And that was bullshit. Jack was sure of it.

“What did you name him?” Daniel asked. He adjusted his glasses as he leaned forward a little.

All of the Etherians seemed interested as well, Jack noticed. Well, given their weird naming traditions - Glimmer, Bow, Catra, Scorpia, Entrapta… - they probably thought this was crucial information.

“Prime. I named him Prime.”

OK, that was interesting. “Like a First Prime?” Jack asked as innocently as he could.

Teal’c, who was doing his stoic silence shtick, raised his eyebrow at that, he noticed

“No. I named him Prime since he was to be the start of the saving of the Asgard,” Loki explained.

“Of course you would.” Jack shook his head.

“And did you explain the meaning to him?” Daniel asked.

“Yes.”

“Ah.” Daniel nodded.

“It was a logical and fitting choice,” Loki retorted.

“He won’t have taken this well,” Hordak said. “Especially if he knew about the Goa’uld customs from your teachings or files.”

Loki stared at him for a moment. “I saw no need to restrict his access to public data. He decided to repay such generosity with a betrayal and attempted murder.”

“Oh, no one’s saying Horde Prime was a good guy,” Jack told him. “We’re just saying that you were dumb as a post about the whole thing.”

Oh, Jack must have hit a nerve - that was a great glare. For a half-pint alien midget.

“Jack!” Daniel hissed.

“What? It’s true!” Jack defended himself.

“Well… it’s still impolite to say it.” Daniel pouted.

“Yes. I am, objectively, amongst the smartest members of my species,” Loki said. “Anyone in my place would have been fooled by Horde Prime.”

For the Asgard’s sake, Jack hoped that Loki was lying about that.

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Adora frowned. Deeply. Hearing Loki tell them about Horde Prime’s childhood…

“He’s worse at this than Shadow Weaver ever was,” Catra muttered.

Adora nodded. Shadow Weaver had been able to manipulate them. Easily. Loki had been manipulated by Horde Prime. Of course, Loki might be lying to make himself look, well, not good, but not guilty. But he wasn’t doing a good job about that, either. On the other hand, if the Asgard hadn’t had children for thousands of years, he wouldn’t have had any clue about raising one. Then again, if that was the case, he shouldn’t have created Horde Prime without first learning how to raise a child.

And he wouldn’t get to raise any new Asgard, either. Adora wouldn’t let him. That would be another disaster. Whether he thought they were Asgard enough or not, he would harm them just by being himself.

Loki looked at her and Glimmer, then at Catra with a hint of a scowl. “I believe that the subject of my relationship with Horde Prime’s clones has been covered sufficiently now.”

“We just said that,” Hordak grumbled.

“Well, there are still several questions…” Daniel trailed off and blushed a little at the glares he received. “But I am sure there will be an opportunity to examine particular topics at a later date,” he added with a weak smile.

“Like in a hundred years or so,” Jack commented.

“Jack!”

“Then I will take my leave and await your call in a week’s time, as we’ve agreed.”

“Yes,” Adora told him with a nod. Loki might be an example of the worst parenting Adora had ever met - and the competition was fierce there, what with Shadow Weaver and Horde Prime in the running - but they wouldn’t let the Asgard die.

Loki nodded at her and Glimmer, then turned and walked towards the Stargate. Adora watched him use the D.H.D. to dial another Stargate, then step through after his drone had passed through.

“So…” she started to say.

But Catra held her hand up, cutting her off. “Did Loki leave any listening devices?”

“Uh…” Entrapta took her tool out and started using it. “Lemme do a quick scan…”

“The scanner hasn’t detected any unknown devices in the vicinity,” Sam reported a minute later.

“Good.” Jack shook his head and sighed. “And I thought the snakes were bad.”

"Jack! I don't think you can compare Loki to the Goa'uld," Daniel told him with a frown. "The Goa'uld - well, many of them - delight in cruelty and deliberately hurt others. Loki seems more as if he acted out of ignorance and negligence. Which would partially be understandable because of his species' history. Provided he told us the truth about that."

"Loki the Trickster telling us the truth?" Jack raised his eyebrows at him. "You sure?"

Daniel blushed a little. "Well, like scripture, the myths of the Norse can't be taken as the literal truth."

"But if he were lying, then why would he want to look as bad as he did?" Glimmer asked.

"He might not have realised that we have different values," Daniel suggested. "Although the fact that the Asgard oppose the Goa'uld and the way they treat their protected planets would contradict a completely different morality."

"He's hiding from his own people," Jack pointed out. "You don't do that unless you are doing something against their laws. Which he admitted."

"Yes. But without checking with other Asgard, we can't be sure where the differences are. And even then, we can't assume an entire species has the same values - Earth is proof of that," Daniel retorted. "And Etheria as well."

Adora knew that. Earth had a list of universal human rights, but they weren't really universal - a lot of the countries on Earth disagreed with them. They had seen that in the United Nations. And Etheria… well, different kingdoms had different traditions. And princesses.

Daniel looked around. "Speaking of checking… do we inform Thor of this? We didn't promise not to, but Loki seems to assume that we won't. At least, that was my impression."

“Sucks to be him, then,” Jack said.

“If we inform Thor, Loki will assume we betrayed him. He’ll probably go into hiding and work on his own plans again,” Glimmer pointed out. “And his plans so far included setting up some dangerous bots to fool his own people or create Horde Prime.”

“And he knows about Alpha now,” Catra added. “He’ll try to find it.”

“Uh… sorry?” Entrapta winced. “I shouldn’t have told him about her, right?”

“What’s done is done. Lying to people isn’t a good idea, either, if you want to earn their trust,” Adora told her.

“But do we? Want to earn his trust, I mean,” Bow asked. “Loki seems like, well, a disaster waiting to happen.”

“Another disaster waiting to happen,” Jack corrected him. “He already caused Horde Prime.”

Adora frowned. Loki was responsible for Horde Prime, but that meant he was indirectly also responsible for creating the Clones. Could she condemn him for that even though many clones were now their friends? If Horde Prime had never existed, would she have ever met Catra?

She pushed that thought away. The past was the past. You couldn’t change it. Not without risking to unravel the very fabric of the universe. Adora shuddered at the memories of that terrible day when Angella had sacrificed herself to save them all.

“We could call Thor and have him arrest Loki,” Daniel suggested.

“That only works if Thor believes us and can arrest him,” Jack said. “He might not have the power to arrest him - or he might not know where Loki is. And he hasn’t warned us about those

genocidal robots they are fighting, either. Which would have been nice amongst neighbours, you know?"

That made sense. But not telling Thor also felt wrong.

"The Tau'ri have a saying: Keep your friends close and your enemies closer," Teal'c said.

"You mean work with Loki so we know what he is doing?" Catra frowned. "That's dangerous as well."

"He does seem fixated on his goal of saving his species," Daniel said. "To the exclusion of any other concerns. If he sees a path to a solution, I don't think he would risk that. Of course, I am not an expert on Asgard."

Adora agreed with him. She looked at the others.

Catra shrugged. "I don't think we want him running around without anyone to keep an eye on him."

"I am not sure we want him near Etheria, either," Glimmer said.

"I don't want to see him again," Hordak said. "But he shouldn't be allowed to continue his 'experiments'."

"Everyone can change for the better. For all that he has done, Loki still deserves a chance at redemption. And who better to show him the way than Your Divine Highness and Your chosen friends and companions?" Priest beamed at her.

"And if we want to save the Asgard from extinction, we kinda need the Asgard," Entrapta said. "At least one of them. Plus! With his data, we can avoid making the same mistakes!"

And they couldn't let the Asgard die out. Adora slowly nodded.

Even though she still had a bad feeling about this.

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The Scientist Part 3

PZ-825, January 30th, 1999 (Earth Time)

They wouldn't inform Thor about Loki's plans. Samantha Carter couldn't say she disagreed with the decision. It was pragmatic, and the arguments for not exposing the Asgard made sense. But…

She glanced at Daniel. She would have expected him to oppose this course of action more strongly. He was usually quite vocal, sometimes even bordering on insubordination, when it came to being honest with other species. Also, he was correct in that honesty generally made it easier to forge good relations or even an alliance with another species. And the Asgard were an advanced species, with technology on par - at least - with the Horde's. Very valuable allies.

How would they react to the Alliance covering for Loki? Of course, they had no obligation to inform the Asgard about Loki's plans, but that was a legalistic argument. The Asgard might accept it, but they would react accordingly to any future proposals from Earth or Etheria.

Sam would have expected the Etherians, the majority of them, at least, but certainly Adora, to push for honesty. Loki wasn't their friend, after all, and as Daniel had remarked correctly, they had not promised to keep his secrets.

"Well, with that settled," the Colonel spoke up, "let's pick up the Stargate. Before Loki calls us again because he forgot something. Like his conscience."

"That's a bit harsh, Jack," Daniel said. "He is facing the extinction of his species - that will heavily influence his decisions."

"And not for the better," the Colonel muttered.

“I don’t agree with his decisions,” Daniel explained, “but I can understand his motives. How would we act in his place?”

Sam nodded. That explained his reaction. Somewhat.

”We wouldn’t produce kids as test subjects,” the Colonel said.

“Or judge them according to their appearance,” Bow added with a scowl.

Everyone nodded at that.

“Of course not! That wouldn’t make much sense. Appearances, even within the same species, can vary enormously,” Entrapta said. “If the genome is similar enough, they’re the same species no matter their appearance!”

Well, the scientifically accepted criteria to decide if two beings were members of the same species was the ability to have fertile offspring together. But with magic and advanced technology, that wasn’t really a good way to differentiate between species any more.

“I don’t think the Asgard agree with that view,” Hordak said.

“Well, they’re wrong! The science checks out!” Entrapta insisted.

“And we can’t assume that Loki’s sentiments towards us are shared by the rest of the Asgard,” WrongHordak added.

“We will have to ask them,” Priest said. “Even if we might not agree on being one species, we are closely related. They are family.”

Sam frowned at that. Priest had studied Earth’s history, hadn’t he? He had probably focused on the various religions, but could he have missed how so many humans were all too willing to exclude other humans from humanity as they defined it?

“I thought you didn’t want to tell Thor what his brother was up to,” the Colonel said, frowning as well.

“Telling Thor might force Loki’s hand - he might have surveillance in place to receive advanced warning of such contact. And as everyone, Loki deserves his chance at redemption,” Priest said. “But that doesn’t mean we should avoid the other members of his species forever. Redemption is not free, after all. Those who repent have to atone as well.”

Sam saw Catra wince at that. Hordak, though, didn’t seem to react, although he might have grown a little tenser.

“You expect atonement from Loki?” Daniel asked.

“I would expect him to do what he could to make amends,” Priest explained. “To use his gifts for the benefit of others in need.” Turning to bow at Adora, he added: “As Your Divine Highness taught and showed us by Your holy mercy.”

“And what if Loki doesn’t want to repent or atone? He seemed pretty insistent that he did nothing wrong,” the Colonel asked.

Priest smiled serenely. “Those who reject a chance at redeeming themselves and continue to harm and threaten the innocents shall be brought to justice in the name of the Holy She-Ra, Princess of Power. Everyone deserves a chance at redemption, but not everyone deserves a second or third chance. The needs of the innocents are not to be sacrificed to save the guilty.”

Catra winced again, Sam saw. But so did Adora. And Entrapta was frowning again.

Sam didn’t want to deal with that right now. She cleared her throat. “Let’s prepare the Stargate for transport.” She much preferred to deal with an engineering challenge, even one as small as that.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, January 31st, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra stretched as she walked over to their bed, then sighed and let herself fall backwards on it. If there was one thing that was the same in the Horde and the Alliance, it was the paperwork. Not in the details - Hordak's forms had been far more detailed, and Shadow Weaver had enjoyed having her redo her reports to add obscure information without telling her why that was important. Probably just to mess with her.

But in general, doing the paperwork after a mission felt the same. You were trying to remember everything that had happened during an operation, even if you wanted to forget it, and you were hoping you hadn't missed something important. In the Horde, you also tried to make yourself look good and blame someone else for whatever had gone wrong. Usually Kyle. You didn't do that in the Alliance. Well, Catra didn't. Lying in reports led to people drawing the wrong conclusions. And that led to mistakes in planning. And failed missions. Which then would lead to more lying.

But in the Horde, not lying would get you punished. Catra knew that very well. At least when Shadow Weaver was in charge. Then again, just existing led to getting punishment from Shadow Weaver if you were Catra.

She sighed again. She was sure people in the Alliance were doing the same thing. The lying, not the punishment. Or both. Not the princesses and their friends, of course. Nor SG-1. Well, they wouldn't lie to make themselves look good, but she wouldn't put it past O'Neill to fiddle with a report to hide some stuff that might have broken some rule. Of course, his superiors, at least the good ones, would also know that.

But the rank and file? They would be doing the same shit to get promotions and avoid getting punished. Hell, the Earth countries in the Alliance were probably doing the same thing, hiding mistakes and blaming others, to look better than their competitors for influence and technology.

It was a damn good thing Adora was the Supreme Commander. She could be trusted.

Her ears twitched when she heard a tiny noise from under the bed. That had sounded like… She rolled over and lowered her head, peering under the bed upside-down.

Two slightly glowing eyes looked back at her, nose and whiskers twitching.

"Luna? What are you doing down here?" Catra asked.

The kitten didn't answer. Probably thought it was a stupid name. So did Catra. But it was the least stupid suggestion from Adora. And Catra… hadn't really felt like naming the kitten.

She sniffed the air but smelt no food, rotting or fresh. But Luna was still acting weird. "You're hiding something," Catra told her. "I know it."

Luna meowed again. Trying to play innocent. She wasn't very good at it - Catra could see through her facade almost as well as Melog could. So, where… ah! She grinned, flashing her teeth as she spotted a piece of fabric peeking out from underneath the kitten's paws. "Stole something again, huh?"

Luna, predictably, ignored her and tried to play it cool. Well, hiding a scrap of fabric was better than trying to hide a stolen piece of fish. Catra still wasn't sure if Melog had actually missed that for an entire day despite the smell or if they had wanted to remind Catra and Adora that Melog wasn't the one who had adopted the kitten and was only catsitting it as a favour.

She rolled off the bed, landing on all fours, then quickly lay down and shimmied under the bed. "Let's see your haul!"

Luna tried to defend her toy, but all she managed was to hang on to it and get dragged out from underneath the bed along the fabric.

Which, Catra realised when she spread it out, was actually a handkerchief. A silken one. With extensive, if now slightly fraying, embroidery. Familiar embroidery.

Catra snorted and petted Luna, who was still trying to get her prize back. "Well, I guess Glimmer has enough handkerchiefs to not miss this one." It was probably not even hers but from a guest room, and those were practically official souvenirs to take with you. Or they should be.

"What would Glimmer miss?"

Ah, Adora had finished showering. Catra turned her head and let the piece drop. While Luna pounced on it and started kicking it with her hind claws - she had a long way to go before she could kill a mouse like that - Catra looked her lover over. Adora was wrapped in a towel and nothing else, her slightly wet hair was hanging from her shoulders, her poof was gone… Catra licked her lips.

"Catra?" Adora raised her eyebrows. She was blushing just a little.

"Nothing," Catra replied, rising from the floor.

"Nothing?"

"Luna stole a handkerchief." Catra cocked her head as she stepped closer to Adora. "It's her new favourite toy."

"Oh. But we got her plenty of toys!"

Catra snorted. "She's a cat. Gifts are never as appealing as things you had to hunt down. You should know that." She reached out and hooked one claw under the hem of the towel.

"But still…"

Catra pulled, and the towel fell away.

"Oh."

And Adora shut up.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 2nd, 1999

At least they hadn't moved the briefing room's chairs. Not yet. Jack O'Neill had already seen some offices in Stargate Command filled with brown cardboard boxes. It looked as if they were moving an ordinary household, not the most important military base on Earth.

Of course, he doubted that the Command Council would accept having to stand during their debriefings. Even - or especially - if that would shorten them. Having the team they were debriefing stand, on the other hand, as if this were a tribunal, would certainly please some of the generals. Especially Sidorov, who probably hadn't stopped scowling at Jack and the others since they had returned through the gate three days ago - and had immediately been swept away for a debriefing by the Alliance in Brussels.

"We've finally received your report, Colonel," the Russian general ground out. "Three days late."

"Time constraints, sir." Jack made an effort not to shrug casually in return. Hammond wouldn't like it, and as much as Jack would love to tweak the Russian's nose, he didn't want to annoy Hammond. The general deserved better than being stuck in a council with the likes of Sidorov. Or being stuck in Stargate Command while the Alliance prepared the biggest expeditionary force ever.

"As short as it was, you had ample time to prepare a report in your spaceship on the way back!" Sidorov snapped. "You could have handed it over the moment you set foot back into this base!"

Yeah, Jack could have done that. Easily. And he had spent some of the time on the way to PZ-825 writing his reports. But that

wasn't Sidorov's business. "I am sorry, General, but I had to check with Alliance Command first to know what parts of the report weren't classified." Jack smiled sweetly at the Russian. Nothing was as sweet as having an excuse that was completely true.

"You were on the same ship as the Supreme Commander of the Alliance! You could have asked at the same time you could've written the report!"

"Supreme Commander Adora doesn't like to unilaterally decide such things unless there's an urgent need," Jack said. Also mostly true.

"I don't think the timing of the report is very important," Petit cut in before the Russian could embarrass himself any further. "Judging from the report, it's obvious that, except for using the Stargate to return, the mission didn't concern Stargate Command."

"That's what the report claims," Li commented with a polite smile. "But then, that is the entire content of the report."

This time, Jack couldn't help shrugging. "The rest is classified, General." No intel for you to pass back to China. Especially not about the boarded Ha'tak they had had to scuttle - that was disappointing enough without outsiders becoming aware of it.

Li nodded, still smiling. China probably had spies in the Alliance already. Though if any of them were placed high enough to have access to the full report was another question. Jack doubted it. The Russians were another thing, of course - the KGB had penetrated a lot of NATO during the Cold War, and Jack didn't think they had dismantled their spy network since then. But even so, information about Loki was classified at the highest levels, so even the Russians might be in the dark.

Might. It never paid to underestimate them. Even if Sidorov was an idiot.

"I concur," Haig said. "This mission doesn't concern Stargate Command."

Hammond nodded in agreement, and that was that. "Yes. You are dismissed, Colonel."

"Sir."

A waste of time, all in all, Jack thought as he left the debriefing room. And the whole song and dance with Sidorov and Li was getting old. He almost couldn't wait until they were officially transferred to the Alliance forces. Especially if it meant he wouldn't have to move quarters twice in a few months or so. Although it wasn't as if he was going to move his home, anyway. He liked Colorado Springs, and commuting wouldn't be an issue for much longer. He might not be able to requisition a shuttle for his personal use - that was reserved for generals - but Jack was pretty sure that if he asked, the Etherians would give him one of theirs. Or have Entrapta build him one, if he didn't mind flying an experimental craft that would probably be faster than anything else and have a tiny little chance of blowing up.

Although Carter wouldn't be happy. She was pretty protective of Entrapta and would see this as an attempt to exploit the woman. Well, it would be, kind of.

On the other hand, the Horde and the Asgard apparently had transporters like straight from Star Trek. If they got something like that set up, commuting wouldn't take any time at all. If it worked perfectly, of course. Both the Asgard and Horde Prime used clone bodies, after all, so they could be replaced easily if there was a transporter accident. Jack didn't have or want a cloned body, and he could wait until Carter and Entrapta deemed the things safe. Wouldn't want to give some people ideas about cloned soldiers, either.

On second thought, he added Bow to the list. The boy was very sensible. Jack trusted Carter with his life, of course, but a third

opinion never hurt when it came to potentially turning your insides out.

Not that it was an urgent problem, of course. Entrapta, Bow and Carter couldn't really focus on the transporter stuff right now, not with the Loki issue to be solved. And the need to find a cure for the Jaffa's immune system problem so Adora didn't have to visit a POW camp every day. And everything else Carter and Entapta were up to - Jack had no doubt that they had many more projects than he was aware of. Like that alien data cube they had found last year.

But that could wait. They had to deal with Loki first.

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Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, February 3rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Research Station Alpha is at your disposal, Adora."

"Thank you, Alpha." Adora frowned a little. She didn't think it was 'creepy' that Alpha sounded like Light Hope, unlike Catra, but hearing the bot always made her remember Light Hope. "We're here to look through the database. Please ensure my friends have complete access."

"Yes, Adora."

Adora narrowed her eyes a little. Was Alpha being honest with her? Or did her programming make her keep secrets? From Adora's friends, or even Adora herself? Like Light Hope? Who had struggled with that until…

She shook her head. She couldn't worry herself over that when she had no way to tell if it was true. Alpha wasn't Light Hope. She wasn't part of a superweapon project that needed She-Ra to betray Etheria. There had been no reason to make her keep such secrets from her. The First Ones had researched and developed

biological weapons here, but Alpha hadn't hidden that from Adora and her friends.

"OK, let's start looking for Asgard genome data!" Entrapta said as she started using one of the consoles in the control room. "If we find the original data, we can just hand that over to the Asgard and their problems are solved! Well, they would still have to adapt their cloning pods to grow different bodies, and they would probably have to alter the appearance since Loki mentioned that his species had looked differently in the past, and they might want to check for what caused the degradation to begin with, but in principle, their problems will be solved."

Adora heard Catra snort at that. Her lover was leaning against another console, watching the big holoprojection where displays of various species flickered as Entrapta was working.

"Hm. There's no 'Asgard' entry. I think. Though the First Ones might have given them another designation - or used a scientific classification instead. Which would be more logical than using a name, I think. Names are sometimes weird, and they tend to change with linguistic drift over time. Or when a language is replaced. And sometimes, they just change. And sometimes, people give others a new name even though they liked their old name. At least on Earth," Entrapta commented.

Catra scoffed again. "Earth isn't exactly a good role model."

More images of different species appeared and disappeared as Entrapta's hair flew over the console's keyboard.

"It's not too different compared to Etheria," Entrapta disagreed. "Mainly, it has more people and less genetic variation amongst them."

"And very different customs," Glimmer added as she joined Adora.

"Well, they aren't too different compared to Etheria during the Age of War," Bow objected. "My dads said they want to look into that period for a comparative research project," he explained.

“The parallels are quite striking, or so they claim - at least after some preliminary research. They will need to travel to Earth to gather more data.”

Adora blinked. “I thought they were mainly researching the First Ones.” They had been visiting Alpha a lot, after all.

“They said that, technically, humans are First Ones. Or at least some of them are.” Bow smiled a little sheepishly.

Catra snorted once more. “I bet they just want an excuse to visit Earth.”

“Well…” Bow shrugged. “It’s probably true. But they said that they wanted to compare how the First Ones affected Earth and Etheria. I’ve told them that they’d be in danger there, at least in some countries, but…”

“Can’t stop them.” Cara stretched. “Well, we could, actually. And we did.”

“Well, they should be safe in our allied countries,” Adora said. And they couldn’t keep people from using the Stargate to travel to safe planets. That wasn’t right.

“That’s up to Earth,” Glimmer said. “So far, they have blocked civilian travel, claiming that they lack the facilities to handle it and want to wait for Stargate Command to move to Canada and get set up in a dedicated base there before allowing visitors.”

“They’ll expect to be allowed to travel to Etheria as well,” Adora said.

“Yes.” Glimmer scowled at the thought.

Adora knew that Sweet Bee was still arguing for free travel. Glimmer said they would settle for limited travel, but it would take some time to hash out how limited. Well, that wasn’t her problem. Adora might be the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, but this was Glimmer’s problem. She had the experience. Sort of.

“Oh! I think I found something!” Entrapta announced. “Let me blow it up. I mean, magnify.”

The holoprojections were replaced with a single figure, slowly rotating around itself. It didn’t quite look like an Asgard, but there were some similarities.

“That’s the original genome of the Asgard?” Bow asked.

“I don’t think so. Though it’s hard to define what the original genome is since we’re constantly evolving. Kind of.” Entrapta shrugged. “We could probably define it as the genome data before they started cloning new bodies.”

“Yes,” Bow agreed.

So did Adora - that sounded logical.

“Anyway, the data entry here mentions signs of genome degradation, so it probably isn’t the original genome data unless they already had that problem before they started using clones,” Entrapta said.

“Alpha?” Adora asked, a little belatedly. “Is that the oldest data you have of the Asgard?”

“Assigning label ‘Asgard’ to degradation data,” Alpha said. “Yes, this is the oldest data regarding this particular species.”

“Oh.” Entrapt frowned. “I guess it’s not a solution, then.” She perked up. “But it should make it easier for them to find a solution. And they can use it to gain more time for more research! So, it’s kind of a solution.”

“Good.” Catra didn’t sound as if she cared much. “So, do we hand the data over to Loki or Thor? Or both? And do we want to invite Asgard scientists to this station?”

Those were good questions. Adora looked at Glimmer. Her friend was scowling again.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 4th, 1999

"...and so we know part of the solution for the Asgard's problems. And if the genome degradation that Alpha projected is correct, or even if it's just close to the actual degradation, then they really do have a serious problem, Sam. If their genome were a structural component of a bot, the poor thing would be on the brink of collapse! Anyway, we decided to meet with Loki first before deciding if we inform Thor about this. Well, if we inform the other Asgard, but we only have his number. And Loki's, but he didn't claim to speak for his species. Although Thor didn't claim that, either, technically, but as Supreme Commander of the Asgard fleet, he does have an official position that seems quite high. Unless he lied, but then Loki would have said something when Daniel mentioned it, at least I think so, right?"

"Yes, I also think so." Samantha Carter nodded at Entrapta. "Although we can't be sure - we don't know much about the Asgard, so we can't assume that they would act and react as we do." Though what they knew pointed at a similar morality. And Thor had seemed to be quite a decent individual.

Of course, con men often made very honest impressions.

"Well, we now have their past genome data, and if they don't have it, and I think they don't, we know something about them they don't." Entrapta shrugged. "Anyway, that's what we got from Alpha. The others are still discussing things. Even Hordak didn't want to do science instead," she added with a pout.

"Ah." Sam nodded again. She didn't quite mind that. Hordak was a remarkable scientist, as Sam knew from both personal experience and the fact that he had managed to recreate advanced technology almost by himself after stranding on Etheria. But he also was a former warlord who had almost conquered Etheria.

And, as the Colonel would put it, he had more issues than National Geographic.

But Entrapta clearly was in love with him. And, at least as far as Sam could tell, the feelings were reciprocated. So, as long as Entrapta wasn't hurting, it wasn't any of Sam's business. Thanks to Entrapta's somewhat enthusiastic habit of oversharing information, she already knew more than she had ever wanted to know about their relationship.

Entrapta hopped off the table she had been sitting on. "I know if we just tell Thor that we found some data about his people's genome trouble in one of our labs, it might look suspicious since we shouldn't know about that unless we were snooping around, but not telling him would look worse, wouldn't it?"

"It's a dilemma," Sam agreed. No matter what they ultimately decided to do, it would have unpleasant repercussions. Either Loki or Thor wouldn't be happy once everything was said and done.

"Yes." Entrapta nodded with a frown, her hair bopping. "It would be so much easier if this was just a science problem. Science problems have clear solutions. Dilemmas don't."

"Engineering requires compromises as well," Sam pointed out.

"That's not the same. Engineering is fun. And you might not get everything in a design, but you'll get something - and more than you had before! But with a dilemma, we'll have to disappoint someone." She perked up. "Although if we solve their genome problem, everyone will be happy!"

Sam winced. For a moment, she pondered agreeing. But that wouldn't be honest. "I don't think everyone will be happy."

"Well, not the Goa'uld, since the Asgard don't like them and if their main problem is solved, they can help us fight the Goa'uld."

Sam shook her head. "Even amongst the Asgard, some might not be happy."

“What? But that wouldn’t make sense! Their species is about to become extinct!” Entrapta stared at her.

“Some Asgard might prefer their species to die out rather than to change in what they might think are too drastic ways,” Sam said. Of course, that was projecting human traits on an alien species. But Loki’s attitude towards the Horde clones certainly showed similar views.

“Really?” Entrapta scowled. “Well, Loki said the Clones were not Asgard enough, even though their genes are, but that was merely an appearance issue. Stupid, but we can fix that. And we would be using older Asgard genetic data, so it would be them.”

“Some Asgard might not want to return to that state,” Sam said. “But I just wanted to say that there will always be someone unhappy with a decision. You can’t make everyone happy.”

“That’s stupid.”

Many humans, and, presumably, aliens as well, were stupid, Sam knew that. And many were petty, cruel, vindictive, sexist and bigoted. “We can’t change that. We can just do our best for everyone.”

Entrapta sighed. “Maybe. People should be less stupid.”

Sam nodded in wry agreement.

“Anyway, let’s do science!” her friend perked up. “We can go over the genome data I brought. And then we can check the new parameters for the stealth shuttle after the testing - I have some refinements I think would improve the stealth device based on the Goa’uld sensors. Look at that!” Entrapta’s hair moved over the keyboard closest to her, and a screen lit up with data. Interesting data.

Sam took a step closer to the screen and started studying it.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, February 4th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and I don't think we know enough about the Asgard yet to make a decision about telling them. About Loki or the genome data."

Catra nodded in agreement with Glimmer's comment. They had met Thor and Loki. Once each. That wasn't enough to know either, much less their species.

But not everyone in the Princess Alliance agreed. Perfuma shook her head. "But is there any doubt that they need our help? That they are threatened by extinction?"

"Well, we only have Loki's word for it," Glimmer replied. "But the data we got from Alpha supports the claim."

"And I don't think Loki's dumb enough to make up something like this when we could easily check with Thor if it's true," Catra added.

"So, we know that they need our help. Then we can't hold back information that might save them." Perfuma looked at Glimmer.

"We're not planning to hold the data back. I just think we should know more about the Asgard before getting involved with… this," Glimmer said.

Mermista frowned. "We jumped to help Earth based on what SG-1 told us. Why should we treat the Asgard differently?"

"Weren't you against helping SG-1?" Glimmer narrowed her eyes at Mermista.

"I was sceptical of their claims," Mermista shot back. "I didn't doubt that we should help them if they were telling the truth."

Ah. So, Mermista was probably just being annoying. Or trying to get back at Glimmer. Catra shrugged a bit theatrically. "And you trust Loki?"

“You just explained that we have data that supports his claims.” Mermista switched to frowning at Catra.

She smiled back.

Adora squeezed her thigh under the table, and Catra swallowed her next comment. She could be good.

“It’s not quite the same,” Adora said. “Or it is, kind of. We will help the Asgard. That’s sure. Just as we decided to help Earth. But we need to know how we can help them without causing more trouble for them.”

“Yes,” Bow agreed. “We don’t want to cause rioting or worse. Earth was bad enough.”

“That couldn’t be helped,” Glimmer told him.

“And that was the fault of the Americans. They decided to keep the Goa’uld threat a secret,” Catra added. “Should we have kept their secret and ignored the whole planet?” That wasn’t how you fought a war. “Besides, Earth people riot over anything.”

“It’s not that simple,” Adora disagreed with a frown.

“Anyway, we can wait with giving them the data until we know more about the Asgard,” Glimmer said. “So we’ll know how to avoid more problems.”

“Don’t you think that hiding a possible cure against extinction will cause problems?” Netossa asked, raising her eyebrows.

“Yes,” Glimmer ground out. “But if we just hand it over, they’ll wonder why we would be aware of the problem in the first place, and then they’ll know that we have had talked with Loki without telling them. So, they would be annoyed with us anyway - but being handed a potential cure should make up for that.”

“Let’s hope you’re right.” Netossa seemed to doubt it. At least, Catra thought so.

“Yes.” Frosta also looked sceptical.

“So, why don’t we tell them about Loki?” Mermista asked. “We already know he’s breaking their laws. And he was planning to deceive them by using their mortal enemy.”

“Which is a very reckless plan,” Perfuma added. “What if some of those Replicators escape? That would be like introducing an invasive species, but much worse, wouldn’t it?”

“It would be an *invading* species.”

Catra’s joke earned her some glares and groans, but she could see that Adora had to struggle not to chuckle, even as she frowned at Catra, so it was all good. And Mermista, Netossa and Glimmer chuckled as well.

“It’s not a joking matter,” Perfuma told her with a pout.

Catra shrugged.

“Yes, Loki is very reckless,” Adora said. “But he is also desperate to save his species. If he has hope that we can help, he won’t have to take more risks.”

“Letting him experiment on the Third Moon of Enchantment seems pretty risky,” Netossa said.

“We can keep an eye on him there,” Bow retorted. “And if he is willing to use those Replicators, then letting him experiment anywhere is a greater risk.”

Catra nodded.

“That’s another argument for telling Thor about him,” Mermista said.

Catra couldn’t disagree with that. But…

“I think he deserves a chance to change,” Adora said.

Ah. Perfuma understood that, Catra saw - she was glancing at Scorpia.

"And we need more information before we can decide how to proceed," Glimmer added.

And between the owner of the moon and the owner of the research station - at least according to Glimmer's claim and Alpha's opinion - that was it. Some might disagree with them, but they didn't have enough support in the Alliance.

"As long as Loki is under constant surveillance, I guess that's OK," Netossa said. She was still frowning, though.

Adora smiled at her. "That's where you come in. If you want to, that is."

Netossa nodded, as did Spinnerella. Others would have been annoyed, Catra knew, but those two had their priorities straight. And they were amongst the most experienced princesses. They wouldn't let Loki get away with anything.

Unlike others.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, February 6th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Waiting for the gate to open, Jack O'Neill couldn't help wondering a little at the differences between Stargate Command and whatever the Etherians called their Staragate area. Not the gear, actually. The Etherians had built their base on the ground, not inside a mountain, but they had used former Horde technology and stuff, which apparently didn't look that different from Earth technology. There were some differences, of course. They didn't have an iris but moved the entire gate into the ground to seal it, and their gate computer looked a whole lot different, as did their power plant. But as far as the gate was concerned, it worked out the same.

No, the difference was in the staff. SG-1 was the flagship team of Stargate Command, and Jack was aware that most other members looked up to them, but Jack and his team answered to General Hammond. And now the Command Council, but that was, well, different. Ultimately, SG-1 were soldiers following orders. Unless the orders make absolutely no sense, a small voice in the back of his mind reminded him.

The Etherians, though, were in command. Glimmer was the Queen of Bright Moon, arguably the most powerful kingdom of Etheria - they laid claims to the moons of the planet! And Adora was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance. Everyone else was either a princess ruling a country of their own or in a relationship with one. And Jack knew how much influence that granted someone.

So, the gate guards, from the two soldiers standing guard at the exit of the gate room to the commander of the entire force here were looking at their leaders, their monarchs, not at - in theory - fellow soldiers.

Jack was both a little jealous - envious, as Daniel and Carter would correct him - and happy that he wasn't in their place. Either place. He didn't think power corrupted, but with power came responsibility. If an officer fucked up, their people paid the price. Jack didn't need more of that pressure.

Though the others seemed to bear it well, he found as he looked at them. Or they hid the stress well. They were raised from birth to take up their positions, of course, and they had led their kingdoms through the Horde War, so they probably were used to it.

Glimmer was joking with Bow, Adora trying not to glance too much at Catra, who was lounging on top of a console like, well, a cat, in a very distracting way - if you were attracted to catwomen. And not to hot, smart blondes in unif… Jack deliberately didn't look at the console where Carter and Entrapta were bent over a

screen doing whatever scientific geniuses did while waiting. They'd share their results, if they were important, soon enough.

So Jack looked at the rest of the people present. Hordak, WrongHordak and Priest formed a group. Jack wasn't an expert on Clones, but they looked as if they weren't comfortable so close to each other. Well, that wasn't his problem.

Netossa and Spinnerella were talking with Mermista and Sea Hawk. The former were holding hands, the latter… Well, if anyone didn't know already that they were a couple, a glance at Sea Hawk's expression when he looked at Mermista and her reaction to his gaze would make it obvious.

Once more, Jack felt envious. Shaking his head, he turned to look at the gate, but Melog caught his eye. The weird cat-alien was looking at him, their head cocked to the side. Jack wasn't an expert on cats, alien or not, either, but Melog seemed amused.

Jack narrowed his eyes. In response, the cat turned to make a point of looking at Carter, then back at Jack.

He gritted his teeth. They had talked about that. The Etherians knew what Carter and Jack thought about the whole thing. Which wasn't a thing in the first place, which was the point. There were very good reasons for the regulations.

Melog's alien eyes flared for a moment, and Jack heard Catra snicker from the side. Great. Telepathic gossiping was a thing. This was worse than high school. Of course, most of the princesses looked as if they were barely out of high school and behaved like it, so he should have expected that.

"OK! It has now been exactly seven days, well, seven days on PK-825, since Loki left the planet!" Entrapta announced. "Let's call him!"

Right. Different planets had different days. Jack wasn't sure Loki had meant seven days on PK-825, but it was a reasonable enough assumption. It was close enough to seven days on Earth - or

Etheria - anyway. If Loki was expecting different days, well, they would find out in a minute.

“Dialling,” Carter announced unnecessarily as the gate started to spin. One advantage of working directly with - or for - the leaders of the Princess Alliance was that no one made a fuss about Carter taking over a console. Of course, that might also be because she was best friends with Entrapta.

Whatever. “Daniel, we’re starting!” Jack called out.

“I noticed!” Daniel yelled back as he closed whatever book he had borrowed from the royal archives of Bright Moon and joined the others near the gate.

“Wormhole stable. Establishing communications,” Carter reported.

A holographic symbol appeared in front of her console, slowly rotating around itself. It looked like an alien letter. Or some scribble.

But before Jack could joke about it, the symbol vanished and was replaced by a little grey alien.

Loki.

He was fast to answer - he must have been waiting for their call, Jack realised. Quite eager. Or desperate. Of course, they already knew that.

“Greetings.”

“Hello, Loki!” Adora nodded at him with a wide smile. “How are you doing?”

“Awaiting your response to my request.”

Jack heard Catra snicker again, and he had to suppress a chuckle himself. Both at Adora trying to make small talk and Loki’s reaction.

“Ah.” Adora flushed a little. “Well, we decided to invite you to the research station, to further discuss how to proceed with helping your people.”

“We’ve found some genetic data, too!” Entrapta added.

Asgard had big eyes to begin with. Loki’s grew a size at hearing that, or so it looked to Jack.

If only he knew if that was a good or a bad thing.

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The Scientist Part 4

Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, February 6th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and this is Alpha's control room. To which you don't need access for experiments, so you're not allowed inside. Not even with one of us coming along."

Entrapta was as blunt as ever. Well, Adora knew that. But Loki didn't seem to mind that - or the restrictions she had explained to him since he just nodded. Or he was good at hiding his reactions. He hadn't really acted impressed when they had entered the research station.

"And where is the genome data you mentioned?"

Or he was just fixated on the data about the old Asgard. Older Asgard, Adora corrected herself. They didn't have the genome data of the Asgard before they started cloning their bodies.

"That's in the central database of the station. It's accessible from any console - if you have the correct clearance," Sam explained.

"I expect I have the necessary clearance," Loki said. "I can hardly work on anything without access to crucial data."

Catra, who was walking next to Adora, snorted just loud enough for Adora to hear. Adora didn't react, though - she knew Catra's opinion about how far they could trust Loki.

"You can access the data for experiments," Sam told him. "But any such access will have to be cleared by Alpha."

"Nothing personal," Jack added with a toothy grin. "But we really don't want you creating another Horde."

Loki frowned at him. "I have learned from my mistakes. And I explained that you can terminate any such experiment if you feel

it’s dangerous.”

“Yeah, see, that’s kind of a sign you haven’t really learned from your mistake,” Jack told him. “We don’t want to ‘terminate’ *children*.”

“Yes,” WrongHordak said, nodding sharply. “People are not experiments.”

Loki didn’t react to him. So far, he had ignored all the Clones whenever possible, Adora had noticed. But was it because he was ashamed of his past and didn’t want to confront it or because he was ashamed of them - or because he didn’t consider them people?

She suppressed a sigh. Whatever his thoughts, one thing was clear: Loki didn’t get why you didn’t experiment with children. Maybe it was a mistake to let him help. On the other hand, Catra and Hordak had taken a long time to learn from their mistakes and change. No, she wouldn’t write off Loki after a few hours. That would be wrong.

“Anyway, that’s why we don’t let you experiment without close supervision,” Entrapta went on, still smiling. “So you can’t make another mistake like that. That would be a shame, so close to solving your people’s problem, right?”

Loki stared at her. “...yes,” he said after a moment.

No, he still didn’t get it. “If you break our rules, you won’t be allowed to continue your experiments,” Adora told him. “We won’t give you access to the data any more.”

“And we’ll hand over everything to the Asgard,” Catra added.

Loki tensed at that. “I understand.”

“OK! Now, let’s head to the lab!” Entrapta’s hair pointed the way, and she marched off.

“I bet he doesn’t understand what we want him to understand,” Catra mumbled as they followed their friend.

“It should be sufficient that he understands the rules and that breaking them will ruin him,” Hordak added - he had been close enough to overhear them.

“Indeed!” Priest said, in a lower voice than usual for him. “Should he betray Your trust, Your Divine Highness, his punishment will be swift and appropriately harsh.”

Adora was tempted to ask what Priest considered ‘appropriately harsh’. Really tempted. But this wasn’t the time for that. But she would have to ask him later - no matter that she wasn’t a goddess, people would assume, were assuming, that Priest acted under her orders. Which, to be fair, he kind of did. But he also acted without her orders.

“And this is the lab!” Entrapta spread her arms and her hair. “Here is where the ancestors of most of Etheria’s population were created by the First Ones! You could say that this is the birthplace of our world! Well, most of our world - we don’t know much about the civilisation before the First Ones arrived, but we know there was one since they, not the First Ones, created She-Ra! Or discovered her, if you think the theory that She-Ra is the embodiment of Etheria’s magic is correct.”

A question they might never be able to answer, Adora knew. And a question that apparently wasn’t merely historical. Some people claimed that She-Ra was ‘the only true princess of Etheria’. Which was kind of weird since Adora was a First One and hadn’t even been born on the planet.

“Based on your species, it seems as if the original civilisation on your planet was an off-shoot of the Ancients,” Loki said.

“Well, that’s possible,” Entrapta said. “But the First Ones didn’t consider them First Ones. According to Alpha, the genetic

differences were too big. Not too big to overcome, of course, since they cross-bred."

"And it's ancient history," Jack cut in - a little forcefully. "We're here to discuss your experiments with Asgard genes. Or, more precisely, what experiments with Asgard genes you aren't allowed."

Loki didn't like that. Adora could tell this time.

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Samantha Carter didn't trust Loki. The alien had made it clear that he only cared about finding a way to stop and reverse the genome degradation of the Asgard. Anything else was of secondary importance. It was equally obvious that he thought all his actions were justified because of his goals, no matter how convoluted. And that he either was incapable of or just not bothering with a rational risk assessment. Not the kind of scientist you wanted to work in a lab, much less this research station.

But given what he had been working on - using a dangerous self-replicating swarm of - probably - artificial intelligences to swindle his way into having access to his species' classified information - it was safer to have him here, under close supervision. Marginally safer.

Although, she added to herself with a glance at the Etherians, who were watching Entrapta explain the lab's various tools to Loki, between Alpha and the princesses, the risk of Loki slipping the leash, so to speak, was probably low enough to be acceptable.

"...and that's where we splice genes." Entrpata finished, pointing at a device sporting a few shiny crystals and some slightly odd controls that took a while to get used to.

"I see." Loki looked around - at the devices, not the people, Sam noted. Although he didn't ignore the Etherians or SG-1 like he did the Clones. He simply didn't focus on them, but the clones he actively avoided looking at.

If Loki were doing that to Sam's team instead, the Colonel would likely annoy him by standing next to or in front of the device the alien wanted to study, Sam thought with a faint smile.

"And where are the resources stored for the experiment?" Loki asked, focusing on Entrapta.

"Ah…" Entrapta smiled a little embarrassedly. "They kind of went bad in the thousand years since the research station was last used, so we have to replace them before we can start working here."

"You have access to a research station of the Ancients and haven't done any work?" Loki sounded shocked.

Entrapta frowned. "We had other projects to work on. Genetic research wasn't a priority so far."

Loki pressed his mouth closed before slowly nodding. "I see."

Sam was sure he had been about to berate Entrapta before he caught himself.

"This should be rectified then," Loki went on.

"Yeah, probably. But we first need to know what we need," Entrapta said, nodding. "There's no need to restock everything, after all. And it would be kinda illegal, I think. And wrong."

"Definitely wrong," Sam agreed. The Ancients had had a very flexible definition of resources for their research.

"Yes," Alpha chimed in. "I had to change the definition of samples to use for research. Sapient species are no longer covered."

On second thought, Alpha probably wasn't as well-suited to limit and spoil Loki's potentially questionable plans as Sam had hoped…

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"We need raw material for cloning. And for growing clones. Nutrients. Cells to alter. For starters."

Catra rolled her eyes. 'We' obviously meant 'I' where Loki was concerned.

Fixated.

She nodded at Melog's comment. "Yes."

"What did they say?" Adora asked.

"Loki or Melog?"

"Uh… both."

"Loki's giving his wishlist to Entrapta, Sam and Alpha. Melog's stating the obvious." You'd have to be blind not to see what Loki wanted.

She felt Melog's amusement. But it soon gave way to wariness.

Danger.

"Danger?"

Loki. Not now. But future.

"We already know that," she told them. "We'll just have to solve the Asgard's problem before he loses his patience." And by 'we', she meant 'Entrapta and Sam'. Unless they needed some Earth professor - genetics were not either one's speciality, she thought.

Of course, Catra didn't trust an unknown Earth scientist that much more than she trusted Loki. "We need to set up a watch rotation," she said. "Someone has to be on guard here at all times. Not just Alpha."

"Are you sure?" Adora asked. "Even the Asgard need to sleep, I think."

“I see three people who are the type to wake up in the middle of the night and then go to the lab because they dreamt of a project,” Catra retorted.

Her lover winced. “Yes. That will cut into our manpower. Unless we use regular guards.”

That was a possibility. But… could they stand up to Loki? Or Entrapta? On the other hand, using princesses as guards was not a good way to wage war, either. “I’d suggest Lonnie and Rogelio, but they come with Kyle,” she said. And Kyle was the last person you wanted in a lab. Or watching a potentially dangerous scientist. Loki wouldn’t have to be the smooth talker from Earth myth to make Kyle help him do whatever he wanted. “We’ll have to see if we find trustworthy people.” And hope they could solve this genome problem quickly, so they could kick Loki out again. If they knew more about the Asgard… No. You couldn’t trust them to rein in Loki. Not when he might save their species.

*****

An Ancient research station specialising in genetic modifications wasn’t Jack O’Neill’s first choice for a travel destination. Or his second. Or third. He really didn’t want to be here, actually. That the computer running the station thought he was an Ancient didn’t change that - quite the contrary. Jack didn’t want anything to do with the kind of research they did here. And would be doing. If the thing asked him for a sample… He shuddered.

“How long will it take you to procure the material?” Loki asked.

“Uh… we should get most of the list in a day, I think. Sam?” Entrapta looked at Carter.

“With the exception of the specific cell samples here, we can procure everything on the list from Earth.” As usual, Carter was the consummate professional. Scientist. Soldier. Officer. In her place, Jack wouldn’t have resisted making a sarcastic remark about eagerness.

“Goody!” Entrapta smiled. “We’ve got lots to do!”

“Yes. The survival of my species is at stake.”

“Yes. But we also need to find a way to save the Jaffa.” Entrapta smiled at Teal’c. “And it’s kind of more urgent for you.”

Right. The Asgard were facing extinction, but the Jaffa would die without Goa’uld larvae to grow in their bellies. Pouches. Whatever. And the prisoners would be running out of time faster than the Asgard’s problems were catching up with them. Teal’c had a few more years left before that would be an urgent issue, but others were not so lucky. Not that Jack cared overly much about the Jaffa prisoners who still followed their Goa’uld masters, but they were prisoners of war, which meant you were obligated to provide them with healthcare.

“The Jaffa are your enemies. Why would you want to save them?” Loki asked. “If you help me save my people, we will help you wipe out the Goa’uld.”

Yeah, right. Jack snorted. He might not be an expert on Norse mythology, but he hadn’t ignored Daniel’s ramblings about Loki’s deeds - know your enemy and all that. Unless the alien had suffered a complete character assassination in those legends, Loki couldn’t be trusted to keep his word. He would promise anything to get his way. And even if he were planning to keep his grand promises, Loki couldn’t speak for the Asgard, and Jack doubted that saving them would result in Loki becoming their leader. That wasn’t how politics worked. No matter the Asgard’s form of government, the current leaders wouldn’t hand over power to a mad scientist who had gone rogue. They’d thank him, of course, but go to war for him? That wasn’t how things worked.

Of course, they had those protected planets, but those were a few dozen planets, tops - nothing compared to all the worlds in the Goa’uld Empire.

“The Jaffa are victims of the Goa’uld,” Adora told Loki. “They are manipulated with lies and controlled by their need for Goa’uld larvae to survive. Our enemies are the Goa’uld.”

Catra looked tense, Jack noticed. As did the Clones.

“You cannot defeat the Goa’uld without defeating the Jaffa,” Loki retorted. “They are loyal unto death.”

“Not all of them are blindly loyal to the false gods,” Teal’c spoke up. “Some realise the truth yet are trapped by circumstances. If they can be cured of their dependency on the false gods’ larvae, they will abandon them.”

“Yes!” Adora nodded.

“You would prioritise such a feeble hope over my people’s future?” Loki asked.

“No. We can work on both projects,” Carter told him. “Cells will take time to grow.”

“Time that can be used to prepare the next batch,” Loki said.

“That would be kind of a waste,” Entrapta said with a frown. “You’d be running two experiments - or more - before getting the first results.”

“I plan to pursue multiple potential solutions.” Loki straightened.

“Well, we have multiple problems to deal with,” Jack said.

“Then it would be logical to solve one problem first by focusing all resources on that. Otherwise, you will have to deal with all problems for a longer time.”

The alien had a point. Kind of. Jack glanced at Carter.

“That is based on the assumption that focusing all resources on one task will not lead to reduced effectiveness and efficiency,”

Carter said. “Something I doubt.”

“Yes. And we don’t know yet which project is the easiest,” Entrapta added. “If we can solve the Jaffa’s immune system problem quickly, it would be a waste to wait until we’re done with the Asgard genome degradation. Or delay working on any other urgent problem we need to solve.” She blinked. “Do we have another urgent problem yet?”

“No,” Glimmer told her before addressing Loki: “If you wish to work here, you have to work with us. You can’t expect us to simply do everything for you.”

Loki frowned. “The survival of my entire species is at stake.”

He was very fixated on that, in Jack’s opinion. “Yeah, but it’s not as if you’re going to die out tomorrow or next month.”

“Unlike some of the Jaffa,” Catra added. “Adora already has to heal one of them every day.”

“A single Jaffa is hardly comparable to an entire species.”

“That’s not how this works! We’re not going to sacrifice people just so you *might* get a cure a little bit faster!” Adora glared at him.

“And the Jaffa are an entire species as well,” Bow pointed out. “Technically. But their needs are more urgent - and will, ultimately, also mean we won’t have as many Goa’uld to, ah, deal with.”

“And having a cure for the Jaffa will greatly benefit our war effort - and help our friends,” Glimmer added.

“And they were kinda first - we knew about their problem before we knew about yours,” Entrapta added.

Loki looked around again.

Jack smiled at him, showing his teeth.

The alien looked as if he had bitten into a sour lemon - or something alien - and slowly nodded. "I see. Then we will have to split up our efforts. At least until we have more data and possible solutions to pick."

Jack was sure Loki would only half-ass his efforts on the cure for the Jaffa. But Carter and Entrapta wouldn't - and he trusted them to beat Loki.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, February 8th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Glimmer was not happy. Adora could tell. Her friend was a bit curt with her subordinates and courtiers - well, more curt in some cases, but they were really annoying - and a bit snappy with everyone else. Even Catra seemed to have stopped needling her when the opportunity presented itself and was now petting Luna, who had apparently managed to escape their room once again.

Which should kind of raise questions about the security of their room, to be honest. Even if Luna was a cat and, therefore, at least according to Catra, 'innately capable of getting in and out of every place she wants'.

"Cheer up, Sparkles. Bow's going to come home in three hours."

Adora's lover was even trying to console Glimmer.

But Glimmer scowled instead of being cheered up. "He is supposed to come back from the moon in three hours. That means he'll return two hours late, dead tired, and babbling about gene sequence cutting or something! Is that OK?" Without waiting for an answer, she started pacing in her office. "I know Entrapta's going to live up there for the next few weeks; she's like that when she is researching something. And Sam might as well join her; she probably sleeps more on the shuttle to and from the moon than at home. But Bow's not supposed to be like them!"

"Well… he's a techmaster, and the research is pretty important…" Adora trailed off when she saw Glimmer scowling at her.

"Techmaster! Not geneticist! He makes trick arrows, weapons, gadgets, computers and whatever else there is to build! He doesn't build *people*!"

Sam and Entrapta weren't geneticists either. Adora didn't say that, though - her friend was already worked up enough.

"Well, he does build tools, and the others need tools." Catra, unfortunately, didn't show the same restraint. Or didn't pay enough attention to Glimmer.

"They should have enough tools there from the First Ones to last another thousand years!" Glimmer blurted out. "Bow shouldn't spend the whole day up there! If they need more help, they can get some actual geneticists from Earth!"

That had been proposed, but apparently, it took the Earth part of the Alliance more time than expected to vet them. Or, as Catra thought and Adora agreed with, it took Earth some more time to decide which country would be allowed to send a scientist because, of course, that was more important than sending the best trustworthy geneticist…

If they took even longer, Adora would have to intervene, diplomacy and saving face and whatever else be damned! They had work to do! And Glimmer really needed Bow.

*****

Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, February 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Have you finished the next sequence yet? The cloning tube is ready. Has been ready for five and a half minutes."

Samantha Carter took a deep breath and reminded herself that being impatient wasn't a crime, even if Loki was obnoxiously so,

and so she couldn't shoot him and claim self-defence. Well, she could, but it wouldn't hold up in a trial. Although Glimmer might understand… Pushing the fantasy away, she looked at Loki. "No, it will take another five minutes for the machine to finish rearranging the sequence." Which Loki should be well aware of since she had told him that two minutes ago.

The alien turned to address Bow without paying any more attention to Sam. "Have you made any progress with a faster machine?"

Bow managed to smile. "I'm working on it, but to improve on the current machine, I need very precise tools, which I have to manufacture first."

"Yes! We need the tools to make the tools to make the tools, so to speak," Entrapta chimed in. She was still cheerful. "But we're working on it!" Of course, part of the reason for that was, in Sam's opinion, that Hordak was living with her on the station. In contrast, Sam had to commute back to Bright Moon with Bow and whoever was on guard duty during the day and then continue through the Stargate to Earth. Where she would have to write a dozen reports. Sometimes, she didn't even see her friends before she crashed in her quarters at the base.

She wasn't envious of Entrapta. Not at all. And if she was, it would be because Loki didn't hound her as much as he did Sam and Bow.

"You can use the time to analyse the latest results from the Jaffa line," Hordak grumbled.

The alien loved Entrapta, and he loved doing science. It was a testament to how annoying Loki's attitude was that Hordak was so grouchy despite being able to work with Entrapta in the lab here. And that was with Loki ignoring him whenever possible while he needled everyone else.

Sam wouldn't mind being ignored for a while; it would make working on the genome problem easier and more pleasant. Not that she was a geneticist. But she knew how to operate Ancient technology, and she had a good grounding n science and genetics - enough to contribute. Though a real specialist would work wonders. If only the Alliance could manage to sort out whom to pick…

"I will study the Asgard genome sequences again," Loki said.

Hordal grumbled again.

And Sam went back to her work.

*****

P.O.W. Camp "Hotchins", Newfoundland, Canada, February 10th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and the Indian Government has ended the state of emergency in West Bengal following two weeks without any major terrorist attack, though the troops stationed there remain on alert according to our sources. Asked about the resolution China proposed in the United Nations Assembly, supported by Bangladesh and Pakistan, to launch an international investigation regarding the reports of human rights violations by the security forces, India's Prime Minister stated that this was an internal affair of India before rejecting the accusations, and accused China of trying to cause a civil war…"

Catra rolled her eyes. More Earth politics. At least none of the countries involved in this mess were part of the Alliance. Although she remembered that part of the problem was apparently Britain's fault, and Britain was in the Alliance. And China was part of Stargate Command.

Well, that wasn't her problem. She reached for her soda when the door to the outside was opened, and a blast of cold air hit her across the mess hall. A number of curses from the people eating here followed.

“Sorry!” Adora stepped inside and quickly closed the door before smiling at the various prison guards seated in the mess hall. “It was a bit more windy than I thought.”

“No problem!” one of the noncoms told her.

Catra snorted. “That’s why we use the main entrance to the building and enter the mess hall from inside,” she told her lover.

“I wanted to take a shortcut,” Adora said with a pout.

“Really?” Catra raised her eyebrows. “Finished healing Haken for today?” Their friends really needed to find a solution for the Jaffa’s health problems; having to visit every day was a pain in the butt. Even with a shuttle, it took them an hour from Etheria and back.

“Yes. But I also had to heal Manut’u,” Adora told her.

“The Jaffa Kyle we captured?” Catra finished her soda.

Her lover frowned. “He’s not like Kyle. He’s just a bit clumsy. He fell down in the bathroom and broke his nose and finger.”

That was… suspicious. “You think he was beaten?” They had split the prisoners who were doubting the Goa’uld and those who were fanatically loyal, but they would have missed some, or some might change their views.

“No. It didn’t look like, well, beatings.”

“Alright.” Catra smirked. “He’s not like Kyle then. He’s worse. Kyle never did that.” She put her soda down. “Want to grab something, or can we leave?”

“We can…” Adora trailed off and looked at the TV screen nearby.

"...and Iran’s government found itself in a rare alignment with its traditional rivals amongst the gulf states in rejecting a United Nations resolution calling for the decriminalisation of magic. So

far, several people have been killed in Iran for 'witchcraft', but none have been officially executed, although at least a dozen trials are underway, and multiple death sentences have been appealed. Amnesty International denounced the anti-magic laws as 'inhumane and prone to abuse'."

Catra glanced at her lover. Adora looked grim, pressing her lips together, as she watched half a dozen pictures of - or so the newscaster claimed - 'witches on death row'. "Do you want us to intervene?"

"We said we wouldn't conquer Earth," Adora replied.

"We wouldn't take over the country. We'd just liberate the prisoners," Catra retorted. "If we get the transporter working, we could do it without setting foot into the country." Well, they would probably need to send a spy bot to identify the prisoners, the scanner might not be enough, but…

Adora shook her head. "That would work out the same - we would demonstrate that we won't respect or accept another country's laws." She didn't sound very convinced, though.

"Well, if the law's evil…" Catra shrugged.

"The political consequences for the Alliance would be grave," Adora said. "Much worse than Princess Sweet Bee and Prince Peekablue pushing for open trade. No one would trust us any more - everyone would fear that we'd invade them if they don't obey our orders and laws."

That wouldn't bother Catra. Most of Earth's countries were run by scum and populated by bigoted idiots, in her opinion. "Didn't they cut back on their demands?"

"Glimmer said they have been talking with more kingdoms about trade with Earth."

"Ah." Another thing to look into. It never ended. "So, let's return?"

"Yes." Adora nodded. "We have another meeting at Stargate Command."

Great. One thing the Horde had had going for it: They had had much fewer meetings, at least when Catra had run it. Granted, that might not have been good overall, but still…

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 10th, 1999

"Victory in space! Allied forces trounced another snake fleet! Our experts will explain…"

Jack O'Neill frowned and switched channels. Nothing was worse than listening to another so-called expert going on about things they had no clue about, half of them retired Navy officers as well…

"...we now have confirmation by Alliance Command that there was a battle in space, though we were unable to get more details except for the fact that while the naval forces involved were Horde frigates, boarding actions were taken by Earth forces. Or, in other words, our marines are now space marines!"

"Careful, Bob! That is a trademark! Alien body-snatching snakes are one thing, but lawyers are another thing! They are much more dangerous and vicious!"

Alright, listening to newscasters making board games references and joking when talking about a war, after good men had died in space, *was* worse. He switched channels again.

"...and so people are wondering when Earth ships will be joining the Alliance Fleet. We can't pull our own weight until we have a Navy - something the Founding Fathers knew already two hundred years ago!"

“We’re not in the Age of Sail any more,” Jack muttered. “And we have an Air Force now.”

“Hm?” Daniel, sitting next to him, looked up. “What was that, Jack?”

“Nothing.”

“Colonel O’Neill commented on the rivalry between the Air Force and the Navy,” Tealc explained.

Jack frowned at his friend, but Daniel nodded. “Ah, yes. I’ve heard about that. There’s been a fundraising campaign to build a Space Fleet, or so I’ve heard. The parallels to the German Navy League are quite interesting.”

“It’s just lobbying as usual,” Jack corrected him. “The Navy pukes really want their space battleships.”

“Well, the Navy League was a form of propaganda - or lobbying - as well.” Daniel shrugged. “But we’re already committed to building spaceships, aren’t we?”

“Yes.” A blind man could see the need to have spaceships of their own. Space battleships. “The Navy’s just trying to use the public to gain an advantage because they know the Air Force was there first. We’ve got the most experience.”

“With gate travel, but not with spaceships, I think,” Daniel pointed out.

“We’ve boarded and taken Ha’taks!” Jack told him. Taken out and taken over. “What has the Navy done?”

“They’ve got experience in running ships and submarines?”

Jack narrowed his eyes at him. “But not spaceships.”

“Well, the similarities are quite obvious. Especially for submarines.” Daniel shrugged again. “I am no expert, though.”

Jack huffed. “That’s obvious. As obvious as the fact that the Air Force should take the lead in space.”

“Or NASA?”

Jack scoffed. “They are so crippled by PR and politics, they haven’t even managed to launch their Mars mission yet. Even though they could just hop into a shuttle and fly over. And they’re a civilian agency, not military.”

“It’s scheduled for next week,” Daniel said. “Sam mentioned a few more problems with the planned base.”

“Excuses, excuses.” Jack turned to look at the TV screen again. Carter was still working in that stupid research station on the moon. Of Etheria.

“...and people are wondering when they will be able to visit our allies’ planets. While most understand that any spaceships are needed by the military, so space cruises are not on the table yet, the Stargate is another thing. We regularly get visitors from alien planets - it’s more like a commute than a trip - and experts have calculated that one could easily slip a few travel groups through with the right planning. Others are already planning for the time after the war, anticipating a sale of used military transports and a corresponding boom in civilian space travel.”

“Don’t count your chickens before they have hatched,” Jack commented, shaking his head. They had barely started the war. Even if everything worked out perfectly, they would be fighting the snakes for years. And in war, you couldn’t count on everything working out.

“Well, there’s no harm in planning ahead,” Daniel said. “Quite the opposite, in fact - we should be prepared for the end of the war. Switching from a war economy back to a peace economy would be a daunting task even without the scope of this war and the advanced technology we will be dealing with.”

“Yeah, yeah.” Jack didn’t really worry about that. When the war against the Goa’uld ended, he’d either stay in the military or retire. Or he’d be dead. “We still need to focus on winning the war in the first place.” He checked the clock on the wall. “And we’ve got a meeting with the Command Council.”

“We?” Daniel looked up.

“Yes. SG-1, except for Carter.” Who was practically living on that moon now. Jack hardly ever saw her any more.

His friend frowned. “That’s… unexpected.”

Jack shrugged. “It was in your daily briefing.”

“I saw it. I didn’t think it concerned me.”

“Well, you were wrong. Let’s go.”

*****

Communication was key, as the humans said. Adora agreed with the sentiment. In an alliance, you needed to know about your allies’ concerns and goals. And you had to ensure that they understood yours. And as the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, it was her responsibility to see that people understood each other. Personally, in many cases - and that meant meetings. She knew that and accepted it.

But that didn’t mean she had to like it. Not every meeting was equally important. Some were even pointless. Or turned out to be pointless. Mostly pointless. Such as this one with the Stargate Command Council.

“...and I think that settles any concerns regarding the Stargate’s security during the move. Thank you, Adora.” General Haig smiled at her.

She smiled back. “You’re welcome. The Stargate is a crucial asset in the war. Of course, we’ll ensure its safety during transit.”

"And afterwards," Catra added. She was still slouched in her seat, but, at least, she wasn't faking a nap. Or actually napping.

Not that Adora could blame her overly much - this whole meeting could have been replaced by a simple request to the Alliance. Or Adora. In fact… Adora suppressed the urge to mention that she could just carry the Stargate out and load it into Darla for the transfer if security was actually an issue. That would be showing off. And belittling Stargate Command - probably the United Nations as well. Even though the Security Council, and through it, Stargate Command, was controlled by Alliance members.

Politics. Glimmer should be handling this. Adora was an officer, a commander, not a politician. Sooner or later, she'd mess up.

Sooner, probably, since she was really bothered about the news from Iran.

"If that's all…?" Catra's drawled question interrupted her thoughts.

"That would be all," General Haig replied. "Thank you for coming."

"It was on the way," Catra said with a slight smirk.

General Petit chuckled at that as he rose, and everyone left the meeting room.

As the generals walked away, Jack faked a yawn. "So, we survived another *very important* meeting. Fortunately, we don't have anything more important to do than attend such *very important* meetings."

"I seem to remember that you dragged me into this meeting, Jack," Daniel told him.

"I was under orders. And why should I have to suffer alone?" Jack shrugged. "Would you have preferred to work on your VIP tour guide?"

“It’s a report about the cultural impact of opening access to the Stargate to civilians,” Daniel retorted with a pout. “It’s not a tour guide.”

“You know what ‘opening access to civilians’ means: Selected rich people going on trips through the Stargate,” Jack said.

Adora frowned. That was news to her. Another surprise. She should have been following that - as she should have been following the fact that Iran and possibly other countries were prosecuting people for ‘witchcraft’.

“That sounds like a security risk,” Catra said.

“That was my main argument against it.” Jack grinned. “We’re at war, after all. Can’t have civilians stumbling all over the Stargate.”

“It’s not that simple, Jack!” Daniel objected. “You can’t just make everything subordinate to the needs of the military!”

“Not everything. But we can’t have civilians compromise our security so they can feel important.”

“Would they do that?” Adora asked.

“In a heartbeat,” Jack told her.

Catra nodded with a snort. “As would many princesses back home. Let’s hope they won’t meet each other.”

“I think they already have during Queen Bee’s visit,” Jack said.

“That would be Princess Sweet Bee,” Daniel corrected him. “She’s not a queen.”

“But a Queen Bee.” Jack smirked. “She’s the type.”

Catra grinned in apparent agreement.

Adora would have to ask her for an explanation. Later, though. “I think that is a concern for the Alliance,” she said. “The risk of

people being captured or even taken over by Goa'uld, revealing all our secrets, is too great to allow such trips."

"It's already pushing it to have your Russian and Chinese 'gate travel familiarisation trips', Catra added.

"Well, can't do much about that other than ensuring those teams are trained as well as they can be," Jack said. "Unless you want to tell the United Nations to take a hike and take over the Stargate for the Alliance?"

He sounded as if he was joking but also as if he wouldn't mind that idea. Adora wasn't sure what was true. It didn't matter, though. "We won't do that," she said. "The Alliance won't use their power to dominate Earth."

"Well, one could argue that the Alliance already does dominate Earth," Daniel said. "They certainly have achieved complete military superiority over the rest of the world. And economically, the Western countries in the Alliance were already superior to everyone else. So, I don't think you can avoid that, or at least the impression of domination."

She pressed her lips together. The Alliance was fighting to free people, not to conquer them. Then she remembered the people in prison in Iran. And probably in other countries. So, some people were planning to use the Stargate for tourism while others were about to be executed simply because they could work magic?

"We'll see about that," she said.

*****

Prison Break Part 1

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 11th, 1999

"Hello. I am Philipp Morrison."

"Samantha Carter."

"Dr Iwan Georgovich."

Samantha Carter shook the offered hand as she looked the man over. She had read his file already, but a first-hand impression was always preferable. A little smaller than the Colonel, a little older than herself, not fat, but not in shape either. He was wearing an expensive suit and matching watch - which fit his file. So, that was the geneticist the Alliance had settled on sending to help them with Loki's request. And their other genetic engineering projects.

He looked around in her lab, then smiled at her again. "When I heard I would be meeting you in your lab, I hoped they meant your spacelab." He had a friendly smile, but he was a bit too… polished. And not just because of his British accent.

Sam chuckled politely. "Ah, that's not actually part of Stargate Command. It's more like a private lab."

He blinked, then grinned. "Ah, the perks of being friends with Etherian princesses, I assume?" He chuckled as well, to turn the comment into a friendly joke.

Sam nodded. "That, and the need for a sufficiently safe distance from Earth for some of our experiments."

"Da!" Iwan nodded. "Embarrassing, blowing up Earth by mistake." He laughed.

Morrison nodded and chuckled, but it felt forced.

Sam also caught him glancing at the Russian. Iwan was wearing his usual clothes, a jumper, pants and sturdy shoes. Sensible for a laboratory but probably worth as much as a single shoelace from Morrison's shoes.

"Well, I shouldn't run into that problem," Morrison said. "I'm not a physicist but merely a geneticist."

His humbleness felt fake, at least to Sam. She might be biased from her experiences with similarly skilled scientists - before the Etherians arrived, when most of her work had been classified, but also afterwards in some cases - but she was sure that Morrison wouldn't be quite as polite if they had met under different circumstances, like at a convention. He probably assumed that her authority over him depended on her friendship with the Etherians, not on her experience and position in Stargate Command.

"Oh, no explosions for you, or dimensional faultlines, but you can make deadly disease, da?" Iwan was playing the dumb Russian to the hilt, overdoing his accent.

Not that Morrison seemed to notice. The British scientist nodded. "Yes, but since we'll be working on a moon, that shouldn't be a problem either."

"Not as long as all safety protocols are followed," Sam said.

"Of course." He nodded, and there was that hint of arrogance she had expected. "Speaking of… are there any special or unusual protocols I should be aware of? This will be my first time working in an alien laboratory." He didn't bother to hide his eagerness.

Of course, any scientist Sam knew would give a body part to be able to travel to Etheria and work in a laboratory built by an alien species with technology far ahead of Earth's sciences, so that wasn't unusual. Sam would probably be as obviously eager in his place.

But he had asked a question. "Most of it is automated and handled by the artificial intelligence running the laboratory," she

said.

His eyes widened. “Artificial intelligence?”

She hid her smirk. That was classified, but since he had been vetted and would be working with Alpha, he was cleared. “Yes. The research station is run by an artificial intelligence created by the aliens who built the base there. Her name’s Alpha, like the station. She’s very friendly and very nice, but she’s effectively an alien.”

“Ah.” He nodded.

He didn’t get it. “That means her morals and values are alien,” Sam explained. “We had to teach her that humans weren’t resources for experiments.”

“Oh.” He blinked. “That’s…”

“Dangerous, da? But exciting!” Iwan grinned. “Different viewpoint, different ideas! Good for science! Just not let it experiment on you, da?”

Morrison’s smile looked definitely forced now. “Yes, I suppose that wouldn’t be a good idea. I’m quite fond of my body as it is.”

“Alpha was instructed thoroughly,” Sam said. “She shouldn’t pose a problem. Now, one of your co-workers, on the other hand…” She smiled as she trailed off and saw him cock his head at her. “His name is Loki. He’s the, ah, inspiration for the Norse god Loki.”

“Oh.”

Morrison looked surprised again - but intrigued, Sam noted.

It looked like he would have to be watched as well during this mission.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, February 11th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"..and so, currently, a dozen people are in prison in Iran, facing death just because they have a talent for magic. There are supposedly more in neighbouring countries, but we haven't been able to confirm that - the various governments didn't release any data. Only Iran made it public. Probably for internal reasons."

Catra didn't smile at Adora's presentation - the subject was too serious - but she felt a certain nostalgia. Adora was, like she had been as a cadet and, according to Glimmer and Bow, in the Rebellion as well, overprepared for her presentation.

"How do we know what they are doing, then?" Frosta asked.

"'Witchcraft' was a capital crime in many of those countries even before we returned magic to Earth," Adora said.

Catra snorted. "Earth has been executing people for doing magic for hundreds of years. Mostly during the time when Earth didn't have any magic."

"But that's… Oh." Frosta pressed her lips together.

"Most countries stopped that centuries ago, though," Adora pointed out. "But not all of them. And, as you already know, a big part of the population of Earth fears and hates magic."

"And there are so many of them… That means that hundreds of millions hate us," Mermista said.

Probably more, Catra thought - two of the biggest religions on Earth thought magic was evil. Well, at least big parts of those religions, and under some circumstances, as Daniel had once explained.

The princesses looked at each other. "They seemed so friendly when we were visiting," Perfuma said. "I can't believe they hate us so."

“Those were our allies,” Glimmer told her. “There are a lot of people on Earth. Some love us, some are our allies, and some hate and fear us.”

“And some are killing people for having the talent for magic,” Adora said. “They want to kill everyone like us.”

“They have been killing people like us - or people they thought had magic - as I recall,” Netossa commented. “We’ve seen reports about such killings.”

Catra remembered those reports. Mobs beating people to death. Or hanging them. Or even burning them alive. And she had thought the riots following their arrival were bad…

“That’s not the same. Those were murders. Not executions,” Adora said.

Glimmer nodded. “It was already suspicious how often the police or the military couldn’t stop those killings, but there’s no excuse for the government executing people because they have magic. Or are thought to have magic.” She leaned forward on her table. “We can’t let them do that!”

Netossa and Spinnerella looked at each other, Catra saw. Then Netossa nodded. “I agree. But wasn’t our stated policy not to intervene in other countries?

“We said we’d intervene to stop a mass murder - a genocide,” Adora said. “Technically, this is a genocide aimed at witches.”

“And at princesses,” Catra added, looking at the others. “At anyone with magic.” Or anyone those scumbags didn’t like. She was sure those people murdering witches would consider her a princess as well.

“How can they check for magic without magic?” Scorpia asked. “Except when they see someone cast a spell, I mean. But I thought they were still trying to figure out how magic worked on Earth.”

“I don’t think they are very careful when checking for magic,” Catra said. “They just torture the victims until they confess.” Bow had mentioned that. Or had it been Daniel?

“If they even wait for a confession,” Mermista added.

“Anyway, we can’t let them do this,” Adora said. “But we need to figure out how to stop them without starting a war.”

“Why not start a war?” Frosta asked. “If they want to murder us all, then that’s all the justification we need!”

“Some of those countries have more people than we have on Etheria,” Netossa explained with a frown. “And we can’t just take out the governments and replace them - the people hate us and want us dead. They won’t stop.”

“And we can’t just bomb them from orbit without hitting innocents,” Adora added. “Like children. And people who don’t want us dead.”

“Also, it wouldn’t be right to kill them all if we can stop them without a war,” Perfuma said, frowning as well. “We’re better than that!”

Frosta looked embarrassed and hunched over a bit.

“We could just remove all the accused witches from their prisons,” Catra suggested. “They’d just disappear.”

“Everyone would know it was us,” Mermista said.

“But they won’t be able to prove it,” Catra retorted. “Just as we couldn’t prove that they let mobs kill witches.”

“It would still cause some political troubles, but we should be able to handle it,” Glimmer said. “Provided we can pull it off without getting caught. Or having to fight our way out.”

As long as they had no witnesses… Catra knew better than to say that, of course. Though she wouldn't shed a tear if a guard or soldier in those prisons died. They were willing to murder Adora. And everyone else in the Alliance.

"We need to talk to our friends as well," Adora said.

"And our allies," Glimmer added.

"And what if they don't want us to intervene?" Netossa asked.

Adora pressed her lips together, as did Glimmer, but Catra snorted.

It wasn't as if anyone could stop them.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 12th, 1999

"Did you know that there are people awaiting execution because they're witches?"

Jack O'Neill suppressed a wince at Adora's question. Barely. So much for a nice joint griping session about certain scientists not leaving their lab on the moon or something. "I think I've heard about that," he said. He had - he remembered a news report, but he hadn't really thought about it. Not with everything else to focus on. A stupid mistake - he should have realised how the Etherians would feel about that.

As expected, Adora frowned. As did Glimmer.

And Catra narrowed her eyes at him. "And you didn't think to tell us?"

"I thought you knew - you watch the news from Earth, don't you?" Jack knew that was a lame defence. Even if it was true.

Adora winced in return, and Catra scowled.

"We don't watch everything," Glimmer said. "There's just too much to watch. We'd need an entire company just watching your news to catch everything."

Something in her tone told Jack that the Etherians would probably have such a unit before long. With the Clone Fleet guarding Earth, they would have enough manpower to spare without pulling people from other assignments. Although… didn't the Clones already watch Earth TV?

"Well, most of the news isn't important," Daniel said.

Jack rolled his eyes. "It's knowing what is important that's the hard part," he told his friend.

"Anyway, that's not the issue. The issue is that there are people condemned to death just for having magic!" Adora spoke up again. "We can't let them die!"

Yeah, as he expected. Jack nodded. Not that he minded the sentiment. The question was how to do something about this without invading Iran and starting a diplomatic crisis. Or a war.

"Iran's not the only country where doing magic is a capital crime." Daniel, of course, just had to make things worse.

"It's the only one - so far - to openly announce that they are planning to execute all so-called 'witches'," Glimmer replied. "That's a little suspicious."

"Do you think they expect you to attack them?" Daniel asked. "That it is a trap?"

Jack didn't think the Iranians would be as delusional to think they could trap and defeat an invasion by the Etherians. "If it's a trap, it's not aimed at an invasion or attack," he said. "They probably expect some concessions in exchange for not executing their

prisoners. Or this is the result of an internal power struggle," he added.

"Trying to use this to build up popular support - or trying to get their rivals removed by us, directly or indirectly?" Catra asked.

"Either is possible," Jack said. He wouldn't put it past anyone in Iran's government to set the country up for an attack in order to get rid of the current leaders. Not even after their war with Iraq. "But are you actually planning to invade them?" God, he hoped not! They were supposed to be smarter than this.

"Not an invasion, no."

Adora's answer didn't make Jack feel much better - her matter-of-fact tone didn't leave any doubt that they had considered this. "Operation Eagle Claw Part 2?"

"What?"

The Etherians looked confused. So, they hadn't been making plans for a prisoner break already. At least not to the point of studying the failed US operation. As thorough as Adora was, she would have found out about it in that case. "The Iranians took the US embassy hostage twenty years ago," Jack explained. "Operation Eagle Claw was an attempt to rescue the hostages. It failed."

"We didn't know that," Adora said. "We'll have to analyse that operation." She marked something on her pad.

They seemed set on their course of action, Jack noted. Damn. This was going to be such a huge mess. And some idiot would blame him for failing to stop it. As if he could!

"What about negotiations?" Daniel asked. "The American hostages were released, after all."

"After more than a year," Jack said.

"If taking hostages has the desired effect, more hostages will be taken," Teal'c commented.

"Yes. We're not going to reward them for… this," Glimmer spat. "They would just keep at it."

They were right about that, of course. But to intervene in another country, especially in Iran… The President wouldn't be happy about this. No one would be happy about this. Not even the worst hawks in Congress, though those would mainly be unhappy because it wasn't the United States doing this. Time for damage control. "So, this is going to be an undercover operation, huh? In and out without anyone being the wiser?"

Adora glanced at Catra, who smirked and nodded. "That's the plan."

"That's going to be the plan," Adora corrected her. "We need a lot more information to do this properly, with contingencies and minimal risk for the prisoners."

"Can't you scan for them and then teleport them out?" Daniel asked.

"If we have detailed data about the prisons' layouts, I can teleport inside," Glimmer said. "But we would need to know exactly where the prisoners are - and everyone else."

"Sounds a bit tricky," Jack commented. And dangerous.

"Yes," Adora said. "And you can't take more than one of us with you if you need to take a prisoner out. That's too dangerous."

"But we have other options." Catra grinned. "Want in?"

Oh, Jack wanted to! To give a black eye to the Iranians who had humiliated the United States? Of course, he'd love that.

But this wasn't the Eighties, and he wasn't a stupid officer any more. And not even Adora would probably get him out of a court-

martial for this. Well, she *was* the Supreme Commander of the Alliance… Still, his career would be finished if he joined the Etherians for this.

"I'd love to," he said. "But it's not that simple."

Diplomatic incidents - and potential acts of war - never were, no matter if Jack wished they were.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, February 12th, 1999

"You want to take action against Iran?" The German Minister of Defence looked surprised - and concerned. As did most of the others around the table, except for the Secretary of State from the United States.

Adora nodded. "Yes. We - the Princess Alliance - cannot tolerate what amounts to a planned genocide aimed at people like us, people with the talent to use magic." Most people winced at the term, she noted.

"Can you call it a genocide in this case, though?" the French Minister said after a moment. "Iran hasn't executed anyone yet, and the number of accused is barely a dozen, with appeals still in the works."

"They haven't executed anyone *yet*," Glimmer spat. "Should we wait until they have done so?"

"Technically, they claim to prosecute people who have been using magic, not just those with the talent to use magic," the Secretary of State commented.

Catra rolled her eyes at that but didn't comment. Adora saw that her tail was swishing back and forth, though - if Melog were here, they'd show Catra's anger clearly.

Glimmer glared at the man. “Are you trying to tell me that this makes a difference? Even leaving aside the question of whether or not the Iranian authorities would actually bother with a fair trial, that would still leave everyone with a magic talent risking death should they involuntarily display magic. Which happens.”

Mostly with magic powers, as far as Adora knew. Less so with spells, but it did happen.

“Sort of like they treat homosexuals,” Catra cut in.

“Well, the Iranians, like similar regimes, are prone to abuse such laws to persecute those who oppose their regime,” the British Foreign Secretary said. “However, they will claim that they are not - technically - committing genocide since they are not persecuting people for their inherent magical talent, only the illegal use of it. This point of view will see some support in the United Nations.”

“We’re aware of that,” Glimmer said. She didn’t add ‘and we don’t care’, but her tone made that clear.

More wincing followed.

“They might bow to international pressure,” the German minister suggested. “And a least abolish the death penalty,” he added.

“As they bowed to international pressure when they were holding Americans hostage? When they were executing homosexuals?” Glimmer scoffed again. “If this is an internal power struggle, they can’t afford to cave in - not that letting them jail people just for being born with magic would be acceptable either.”

“We do not expect the Alliance to become involved here,” Adora told the others. “But we cannot and will not let people like us get murdered for being born that way - no matter how they try to excuse it.”

“Many countries will see this as using genocide as an excuse to intervene in another country to force your own values on them,” the German minister pointed out.

"It *is* a planned genocide," Glimmer retorted. "And we clearly said that we would intervene to stop a genocide. We won't wait until they have killed so many people that even the United Nations will call them out."

Adora pressed her lips together. Based on what they knew of Earth's history, that point might never come, depending on the political interests of certain nations.

After a moment, the French Minister leaned forward. "And what exactly are you planning?"

"The exact details are classified," Adora told him. They couldn't risk a leak of their plans; Jack had been quite clear about that danger, even if he had been a bit sneaky about letting them know. It was already dangerous to tell so many countries that they would stop the Iranians, but not telling them would be worse - an Alliance needed trust amongst its members. And they couldn't just bully the rest of the Alliance. Well, they could, but it would be wrong.

"We're not intending to occupy the country," Glimmer said. "Just limited action to achieve our goals."

That didn't seem to reassure the others.

"Are you planning covert actions, then? With plausible deniability?" the Foreign Secretary asked.

"That depends on several factors," Glimmer said.

Catra snorted, softly, next to Adora. It mostly depended on the Iranians, Adora knew. If the Iranians wanted to keep things quiet, the Princess Alliance wouldn't announce their actions. Not that Adora expected the Iranians to do so. They had announced the planned executions, after all.

"Whether or not you have plausible deniability, this might spark more terrorist attacks," the Secretary of State pointed out. "Iran is

financing several terrorist organisations that they can use for that."

"We're also aware of that," Glimmer said. "But we're already a target for most of those organisations."

Adora nodded, remembering the attack in India, although those people hadn't been financed by Iran, as far as she knew. And she clearly remembered the many, many protests with people burning her and her friends in effigy…

"They won't just attack you, though - as your allies, we will be targets as well," the German minister said. "And easier targets."

"You're already targets." Catra scoffed. "That won't change anything."

Adora frowned at her. That was a very callous thing to say. Even if it was correct. "If you are attacked as a result of us stopping a genocide, we'll react appropriately." It should be considered an attack on the entire Alliance, in her opinion, but Earth politics made things more complicated. The Alliance wouldn't conquer the world. It couldn't - not without becoming the same thing they fought against, oppressors.

And that Adora wouldn't let happen. Just as she wouldn't let people murder others just for being born differently.

*****

Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, February 12th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Alpha's holographic projection appeared in front of Samantha Carter and Morrison as soon as they stepped out of the shuttle in the hangar.

"Hello, Alpha," Sam greeted her. "This is Dr Morrison. He will be assisting with our work. Philipp, this is Alpha. She's controlling the

research station." For all intentions, she *was* the research station, but Morrison should realise that already.

Alpha cocked her head slightly to the side and looked at the scientist. "I have added his data to my memory banks. I assume he will be working under the same restrictions as the other visitors?"

"Like Loki, yes," Sam clarified. Alpha considered everyone but Ancients 'visitors' - including Entrapta and Sam - so it paid to ensure that Morrison wouldn't be given the same levels of access.

"Noted," Alpha replied.

Morrison nodded, looking around in the hangar. "Very impressive."

The hangar sported a few shuttles and spare parts, in case of emergencies. Enough to build a spaceship out of them, as Entrapta had specified. And First Fleet had provided, at Hordak's request.

Sam shrugged. "You get used to it quickly. It's no different than any other commute when it comes down to it." She knew she was laying on the 'veteran Stargate and space traveller who has seen everything', but Dr 'Call me Philipp' Morrison probably needed the occasional reminder why she was his superior on this project.

He laughed. "That's one way to talk about travelling half the galaxy for work! Well, we don't have to deal with traffic jams, at least."

Sam suppressed the urge to correct him - the distance between Etheria and Earth wasn't even close to half the galaxy. "Yes. This is a priority project, after all."

He smiled with just a touch of pride. Or arrogance. "So I was told. Multiple times."

Sam nodded. "Now, let's head to the actual lab."

As expected, Loki was already - or still - working when they walked into the main lab, though he stopped and turned to face them when he noticed the newcomer.

Morrison held out his hand. “Hello. I am Dr Morrison. Philipp Morrison.”

Loki cocked his head to the side and eyed him - not unlike Alpha’s reaction, Sam noted. He ignored the outstretched hand.

She rolled her eyes, both at Loki’s rudeness - he was familiar with the custom of shaking hands by now - and at Morrison’s attitude. “And this is Loki of the Asgard. They have different customs.” As Morrison would be aware of.

“So I gathered.” Morrison smiled at the alien as he let his hand drop to the side. “Your reputation precedes you.”

Loki nodded, rather curtly. “Are you Earth’s best geneticist? I, we, were promised Earth’s top scientists.”

“Ah, I wouldn’t go that far,” Morrison replied - with what Sam was sure was false modesty, though he was probably not too far from the best. “I am considered to be amongst the best in my field by my peers, though.”

“Then you should be helpful.” Loki nodded. “We have a lot of work to do.” He turned away to get back to his work. “I assume you will need to familiarise yourself with the ‘classified equipment’ in the station. Once you’ve done so, you can start contributing,” he added without looking at either.

Morrison blinked, then glanced at Sam with a wry expression. “I can see that working here will be an experience.”

Sam snorted. “You have no idea.”

He looked around. “I was under the impression that Princess Entrapta also worked on this project.”

"And Hordak," Sam confirmed. "They should arrive shortly - they had other duties to attend to."

Loki grumbled something Sam didn't catch, but she already knew he disapproved of the idea that there was anything important enough to drag the others away from the work in this lab. Such as reporting to Stargate Command, writing reports, socialising with your friends or sleeping in your bed at home instead of a cot in the lab. Though sleeping in the lab wasn't really a sacrifice, of course - Sam had done that a few times.

And speak of the devil. Sam smiled when the door opened and Entrapta and Hordak entered.

"Hi! You must be Dr Philipp, right? I read your file. I'm Entrapta, and this is Hordak. We'll be your lab partners for this project." Entrapta swept forward and stopped right in front of the surprised scientist. "You'll like it here - it's sooo cool to work with First One technology in an entirely new field! I keep telling Perfuma she should visit; she'd love to work with some of the plant samples here. Anyway, sorry for being late, we had to help our friends with the preparations for a classified mission I think everyone knows about - well, every one of our friends - but we're still not supposed to talk about it, so we won't. That's why Bow's not with us, either - Glimmer told him they needed him for that project. But you'll meet him soon, I think. Or we can stop at his office in the Palace on the way back - wait, it's still classified, and you and Sam will be going back to Earth, not to the Palace. Sorry, my mistake! But you'll meet him soonish, no worry! It's just that he has a new project right now. Which you don't need to know about, as I said."

Morrison blinked. "Uh…"

"It's classified. It won't affect your work here," Hordak told him with his customary scowl.

"Yes?" Morrison blinked again. "I mean, I hope so, though without knowing what it is, I obviously cannot be certain about this."

Was he fishing for information about the intervention in Iran the Etherians were planning? Anyone cleared for this work should know better than that. Or shouldn't be this obvious, at least. Unless that was what he was counting on. On the other hand, the idea that a renowned geneticist would also be a trained undercover operative was ludicrous. Still, Sam wished the Colonel was here. He had more experience with this sort of thing.

"Anyway!" Entrapta turned away, her hair tendrils flaring as they grabbed tools from her own workspace. "Let's do science! We've got two species to save!"

Morrison blinked once more before he started smiling again. "Oh, yes. That's what we're here for, after all."

"Yes," Loki added from behind his table. "So you should stop wasting time."

Morrison frowned as he looked at the alien.

"Don't mind Loki. That's just how he is," Entrapta said.

"Rude and abrasive," Hordak added.

"Anyway! Did you show him the gene splicer already, Sam?"

"I was about to when you arrived," Sam told her friend as she walked over to the tool in question.

As her friend had said, it was time to do science now. And find out if Morrison was as good as his reputation claimed.

*****

Evin, Tehran, Iran, February 13th, 1999

Scanners were nice and useful, but nothing beat personally taking a look. Especially if you were planning a dangerous mission for and with your friends. If Catra had followed that rule a bit more

during the war… Well, to be honest, overall, things probably wouldn't have gone much differently.

Catra snorted at her idle thoughts.

Good news already?

"Just some stray thoughts," she told Melog before leaning forward on the railing and peering through her binocs again.

From this position, right on top of a smaller skyscraper - or maybe it counted as a taller high rise? Catra didn't know the exact definitions and didn't really care - she had a good view of the Evin Prison. At least for an overview. "They definitely increased security," she whispered. The data they had gotten from the United States and the British hadn't shown so many guards. Or so many heavy weapons emplacements - a lot of them anti-aircraft artillery and surface-to-air missile launchers. With at least two sensor units - radar, as the humans called it. Which wasn't able to spot a stealth shuttle, as they had confirmed.

"We've expected that," she heard Adora reply over the comm channel.

"Would've been nice if they just trusted their god to guard their prisoners." Catra snorted again. "But someone in their government seems to be somewhat competent." She could spot patrols moving outside the prison, soldiers with their weapons ready. Zooming in on one such group, she scoffed. "Revolutionary Guards." Supposedly Iran's best soldiers. Certainly their most loyal. According to what their allies had told Catra and her friends, the Iranian propaganda that all of the Revolutionary Guards were ready to lay down their lives on the orders of their leaders wasn't too far from the truth. As fanatical as Horde Prime's Clones had been. Or most Jaffa were.

"We won't be able to scare them away, then. If it comes to that," Glimmer said over the comm.

"Not easily," Catra agreed. Even those who might want to flee - there were always some in every unit - would be held back by the threat of getting killed by their comrades. "But they have to spot us first."

"Not all of us can turn themselves invisible," Glimmer shot back.

Catra grinned and glanced at Melog. They could - and could extend that to Catra. If anyone was checking this spot, they would see an empty roof. And Catra was sure that the Iranians regularly checked any location where the prison could be observed. The spots closer to the actual prison complex would be permanently guarded - she had already seen a few not-so-hidden guards on the flat roofs of nearby buildings.

Can also frighten soldiers.

Right. Melog's illusions were powerful. And they were dealing with *religious* fanatics.

"I think we can do something with that," she muttered.

"What did you say?" Adora asked.

"Nothing," Catra replied. It was just an idea for now. And Adora would hate it. "I'll have to take a closer look." She had seen all she could from this spot.

"No! The place is crawling with soldiers!" Adora protested at once.

"We're invisible," Catra retorted. And she had sneaked around in more dangerous spots.

"They probably have dogs."

Right. She had seen one of those stupid animals with a patrol. "Aren't they supposed to be unclean or something in their religion?" she muttered.

"They're hypocrites," Glimmer said. *"But you can return to the shuttle, and we can fly over."*

"We can also use a spy bot," Adora added.

"We can't get close enough with the shuttle." Not with the birds flying around - someone must be feeding them. "And the spy bot isn't invisible," Catra pointed out. And she really needed to take a personal look at things. Up close. Staying behind and relying on scanners and bots was a recipe for disaster. Sooner or later, you'd miss something important.

"It's too dangerous!"

She rolled her eyes at Adora's outburst. "They've got a park with a restaurant and tea house next to the prison. It's not like they have created a death zone around it."

"They probably have staffed either with guards," Glimmer said. *"This might be their plan - a trap for one of us, to get a hostage."*

That was… possible, Catra had to admit. It would make some sense. On the other hand, the Iranians had no idea what the Alliance could do. "They won't catch me," she said.

"Catra!"

She felt guilty at the worry she could hear in Adora's voice. "We need to save the prisoners," she reminded her friends. "And we need good intel for that. Or we risk walking into a trap. Or making a huge mess."

"But…"

"And if things go wrong," Bow cut in, *"we'll rush down and get you out. Nothing they have down there can get through our shields."*

Nothing they knew about could get through their shields. Not fast enough to stop them, at least. But that didn't mean there was no

danger - especially when picking up someone. But the guards wouldn't spot, much less catch Catra and Melog, so the point was moot. "See? We'll be perfectly safe."

Illusions also help.

"Yes, Melog." Though using illusions now would ruin the idea she had. "Anyway, we're going in," she announced.

"Catra!"

"I'll be careful, don't worry!" Catra told Adora as she swung over the railing and started to climb down, followed by Melog.

Whether the building was a high rise or a skyscraper, it was a good climbing spot - Catra only had to use her claws in a few spots and quickly reached the streets below. Melog easily kept up. Cats were kings of climbing.

Navigating the streets was easier than she had expected - there were far fewer people out the closer she got to the prison, and those who walked the streets there generally hurried and kept their heads down. They were afraid, she realised, watching a family cross the road and almost throw themselves into the shop there. But were they afraid of an attack on the prison or afraid of the soldiers patrolling the streets and manning the checkpoints and weapon emplacements? Or both?

The information the Alliance had about the internal situation of the country ranged from 'teetering on the brink of a counter-revolution' to 'united against a perceived common enemy of their country and faith', which meant it was basically worthless. Of course, the NATO spies and analysts had the excuse that the revelation of aliens and the restoration of magic had changed the whole world, making most old intel worthless, but still! Catra didn't expect some spy work straight out of the Earth movies, but a bit more than pages upon pages that condensed into 'we don't really know' would have been nice.

Another reason to have eyes on the ground. Though just observing the people didn't tell Catra much about their thoughts. They clearly didn't want to stay near the military, but that could just be because you didn't have to be a genius to know that soldiers would draw fire in an attack and that most attacks didn't really discriminate between targets in the area. Or it could be because the soldiers in question were fanatics looking for spies, saboteurs and infiltrators and might mistake you for one.

Well, she wasn't here to analyse the politics of the country. She was here to scout out the prison to free the sorceresses inside. And it was clear long before she reached the park next to the prison that the Iranian military expected an attack - the soldiers on patrol were twitchier than a Horde scout squad in the Whispering Woods at night.

Easily confused.

She nodded at Melog's comment. Yeah, a quick illusion would have half the soldiers shooting each other. But that wasn't what they were here for.

She cut through the park, dodging both patrols - and their dogs - and checkpoints. Being invisible made it so easy, it felt like cheating in a cadet exercise. Hell, even as a cadet, without her experience and Melog's help, she probably would have managed it. The Revolutionary Guards might be fanatics, but they weren't as good as Bright Moon's best. Adora and the others had fallen silent, not wanting to distract her at a crucial moment, no doubt.

She reached the edge of the prison's close perimeter. The Iranians had reinforced the defences here as well. Razor wire, concrete walls with more firing positions - covering both the perimeter and the interior, she noted - than the original ones, and… She peered at the ground, freshly ground up after the construction. Yes, there were mines; she could see the hints. It looked like she had been wrong about the lack of a death zone.

But the Iranians hadn't gone far enough. The mine fields didn't cover enough ground, and the razor wire and walls weren't big enough, either. They might stop a human infiltrator, but she wasn't human.

"Let's go climb a bit," she whispered, checking that no patrol was nearby.

Yes.

Catra burst out of the bush she had been hiding in, crossed the path in front of her and jumped. She soared over the minefield and the razor wire, hitting the wall of the prison behind them, claws digging into the concrete to get a grip. A moment later, she had scaled the wall to the top, followed by Melog. They'd left a few scratches, but she didn't think anyone would notice.

And they were in the prison - technically. On the roof of a building, and close enough to the soldiers crewing the anti-aircraft gun there to smell their snacks, but inside the perimeter. She crawled forward, to the edge of the roof, and peered into the yard below.

She didn't see any prisoners out, but that had been expected. None of the aerial pictures had shown any prisoners there for a while. But…

She blinked, her ears twitching. Had that been? She cocked her head. Yes. Screaming. Faint, but not faint enough to escape her.

It came from the building next to her.

She didn't have to climb down. She simply dropped to the ground and dashed across the yard. Reaching the window from which the screams came was even easier - the bars made for convenient handholds that let her peer inside.

Leaving without ripping the bars off and the prison guards behind it, and everyone else involved, to shreds, instead continuing to scout out the prison's defences, was harder.

Much harder.

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Prison Break Part 2

Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 13th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill knew that he technically shouldn't be here. On Darla, a spaceship belonging to a foreign country that was about to start a hostile operation against another country that would violate said country's territorial integrity. Especially since they were currently directly above that country - if he looked out of the window, he could see the Persian Gulf below them. Depending on which theory you followed, they were inside Iranian airspace - and Jack was well aware that as a member of the United States Air Force, he had no business entering Iranian airspace without clear and legitimate orders. Orders which he had not received in this case.

On the other hand, another theory limited a country's airspace to 19 miles, far below their current orbit. And, of course, Iran didn't have any means to contest the orbitals. Further, the Etherians were allies of the United States, and he *had* received clear orders to provide them with all the support they desired in a blatant attempt to butter them up (also using his personal friendship with the Etherian leadership) so they would favour the United States over any other country. Especially England, France and Germany. Also, Iran was an enemy of the United States, even if they weren't at war. Yet.

But, and that was important for such situations, no one - officially - knew about his presence here, and no one would know unless he got caught. In which case he'd have much worse problems. Most importantly, though, he was needed here. Someone had to be the voice of reason, and it didn't look like anyone else cared for that job right now. Not even Bow.

Quite the contrary, in fact.

"...and we can neutralise all their air defences with precision fire. Or a few special bombs, where we want to avoid hitting anyone

nearby," Bow suggested.

"Giant trick arrow?" Catra grinned.

"Essentially, yes." Bow nodded. "I've been thinking about that for a while, made a few prototypes. I haven't tested them yet, but the concept's solid."

Catra nodded as well. "No test like a field test, right?"

"Uh…" Adora frowned. "We don't want to let the Iranians pick up advanced technology if a bomb doesn't get off. Or reverse-engineer your formulas from the residue even when it goes off."

"Depends on what sort of Iranian government is left after we're done," Catra retorted.

Uh-oh! Jack winced. "I didn't think you were going for a regime change," he said.

"They're torturing their prisoners!" Catra spat, baring her fangs. "I saw it!"

Melog, sitting behind her, was glowing brightly in what Jack assumed was the anger colour. The catwoman was spitting mad. He could understand that, of course - if he had witnessed torture, he might not have been able to control himself. But… "Changing a regime means you'll be stuck propping the new regime up for a long time. And maybe a civil war. A dirty, bloody civil war. At least, there'll be a purge of the old regime's leaders and flunkies, and that kind of purge is never clean." He shook his head. "We - the United States - did that in Iran, actually. And it wasn't pretty."

"Yes, we've read about your coup. And the revolution." Glimmer scoffed. "But we can't let the current government torture its people."

"That would be wrong," Adora added with a grim expression. "Very wrong."

Catra nodded. Jack noticed her tail swishing back and forth. Agitated like a cat's, he thought. "Pretty much any government should be an improvement over that," she said. "And if it's not, we can topple that government as well and hope the next one is smart enough to learn that they can't torture people any more."

"Or execute people for being gay. Or having magic," Bow added.

More nods followed from all Etherians. Jack wished he had taken Daniel with him. In hindsight, it had been pretty dumb to think that Daniel's morals would be a problem instead of what Jack needed to prevent the Etheians from starting another war in the Middle East. Or a series of wars. "Last time the Iranians changed government, their neighbour invaded and started a war that lasted for years. And that wasn't a good neighbour - worse than the current Iranian regime, I'd say."

"Iraq? You defeated them and destroyed their army, didn't you?"

"They've rebuilt." To some degree, at least, but that was a detail. "And they're not the only neighbouring country that might invade. Or intervene."

Catra shrugged. "Most of those countries want to kill sorceresses as well. And torture people."

That was… not wrong. But not helpful. "But in a war - or a civil war, or an insurrection - a lot more people will die. Many of them innocents." Jack felt like a hypocrite, given his past.

"That would be the fault of the regime - or those who start a war," Glimmer said. "We can't just let them torture people because things *might* turn even worse if they were removed."

"Yeah, but you can save their victims without starting a war, can't you? That was the plan, at least as I remember it," Jack said.

"Yes. That was before we discovered how bad that prison is - and how many people they torture. Many more than just the ones accused of using magic," Adora said.

Catra nodded with a grim expression.

Jack shrugged before he could help it. “Well, if you want to stop all torture, you would be better off freeing every prisoner instead of trying to change the regime.”

He watched how the Etherians looked at each other in response to his comment with a sinking feeling in his stomach.

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“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. “We need to save everyone!”

Catra nodded as well, though she was smirking at Jack for some reason.

“Ah… that’s a tall order,” Jack said, wincing. “You’re talking about hundreds, perhaps thousands of political prisoners. You can’t just make them disappear without a trace - I mean, free them without being obvious about it.”

“I think that’s where your plausible deniability comes in,” Glimmer said. “Everyone knows you did it, but they can’t prove it.”

Which was a weird concept, in Adora’s opinion. Innocent until proven guilty worked fine for a trial - Earth had a very good idea there, and she really hoped that would be implemented on Etheria as well. But neither war nor politics were trials. If everyone knew you had done something, people would act accordingly. And it wouldn’t let people save face, either.

“That won’t stop terrorist attacks,” Jack retorted.

“The Iranians already said they wanted us dead,” Glimmer said with a sneer. “Didn’t we replace the United States as the ‘Great Satan’?”

“Ah, I think they settled on you being the Satanic Whores or something,” Jack said, then winced again. “Sorry.”

Glimmer scoffed. “I don’t care if they want to insult us. Especially not if it’s such a childish insult.”

“Not sophisticated enough?” Jack grinned again.

Glimmer snorted. “And not personal enough. Most princesses wouldn’t be caught dead using such an insult.”

“Mostly because that would be grounds for a duel,” Bow cut in. “Historically, at least.”

“Yeah, if you’re talking to people wielding magic powers, it pays to be polite,” Jack said.

“Or to just be good enough to cut them down if they fight you,” Catra added. “Anyway, if we want plausible deniability, we can’t just park a frigate at the prison and load it full of prisoners. We need to be a little more subtle.”

Adora nodded. “And we need to be quick - that prison is not the only prison where they torture people. If we attack it, they’ll expect attacks on their other prisons.”

“You want to hit every prison in Iran?” Jack’s eyebrows rose.

“Yes,” Adora told him. “We want to stop the torture.”

“I don’t think they just torture the political prisoners,” Jack said.

“Yes?” That was obvious from the intel they had received from the Americans.

“Do you want to free *all their prisoners*?” Jack blurted out.

“Well, isn’t it a basic principle that if you’re innocent until proven guilty in a fair trial?” Adora cocked her head. “And if people torture you, or you have to fear torture, can you claim it’s a fair trial?”

Jack opened his mouth, then closed it again and pouted a little. "Yes, but some of those prisoners might be actual criminals."

"What was the saying? 'It's better to let a hundred guilty men go than imprison one innocent'?" Glimmer cocked her head.

Jack sighed. "Yeah. But most people never expect that to be taken so literally." He smiled wrily. "But now we're talking tens of thousands of prisoners! Where do you want to take them all? Most countries won't take in criminals!"

"Even if they were tortured?" Adora frowned. That was… a bit hypocritical. More than a bit, actually.

"Do they have proof for that?"

"So, it's guilty until proven innocent in that case?" Catra asked.

"It's not like that." Jack shook his head. "Look, I'm just saying - you can't take every prisoner and expect Earth to take them, no questions asked. That's impossible."

Adora frowned. If that was true… Well, she trusted Jack. But to leave people behind like that, to be tortured? Maybe they could move them to Etheria? Or another planet? But they didn't have the structures set up. And what if those people didn't want to leave Earth? And their families? They might not like magic and wouldn't want to be ruled by princesses.

"Then we'll need to find out who got tortured, and free all of them," Catra said. "And all their political prisoners. Your countries won't refuse to take in political prisoners, right?" She all but glared at Jack as if he was responsible, Adora saw.

Jack slowly nodded. "No, political prisoners and proven victims of torture wouldn't be refused."

"Not if we deliver the proof, right?" Catra bared her fangs.

Jack chuckled. "Yeah."

“Then we need to get that proof - and the prisoners,” Adora said. That would complicate things.

“And how do you plan to rescue hundreds, possibly thousands of prisoners?” Jack asked. “I’m just curious,” he added with a grin.

Catra snorted again. “Well, Eagle Claw showed us how not to do it.”

“We thought about using a Stargate, but the logistics won’t add up,” Adora said. Power wasn’t the problem, but transporting the Stargate and setting it up would take too long for the number of prisons, and getting a Stargate for each prison would take far too long - if they could even find enough Stargates that they could safely pick up. “So, we’ll have to use stealth shuttles.”

“And a distraction, of course,” Catra added.

“But first, we need the Iranian prisoner files,” Bow said.

Adora nodded once more. They might not be honest in their reports - she didn’t think they would record their torture sessions in official documents - but there should be data to pick it up anyway. And, of course, their political prisoners and the sorceresses they accused would be listed as such. And they would find the families of the prisoners that way as well. “And we have an idea how to get them,” she said, smiling.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 14th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter felt a little guilty. She should be on the Third Moon of Enchantment, working on the cures for the Jaffa and the Asgard. And keeping an eye on Loki and Morrison. Not here, on Darla, working on hacking into the Iranian government’s files. Entrapta and Bow could do that on their own, after all, and Sam helping with an Etherian operation on Iranian soil was a diplomatic nightmare.

That she technically was merely providing technical advice, not active help, and could be claiming to be following orders with regard to their alliance with Etheria, wouldn't impress anyone. If her superiors wanted, she could be punished for this. They wouldn't do it, of course, since that would lead to pointed questions from the Etherians - and from the press and public as well as from the war hawks in Congress. Iran was a hostile country, after all. That she was helping to save Iranian prisoners from being tortured would also weigh in, but not nearly as much as her friends seemed to believe.

But Sam wanted to do this. And she needed a break; you could only tolerate Loki's antics and Morrison's attitude for so long before you started fantasising about lab accidents and 'accidents'. She still couldn't help feeling a bit guilty about leaving others to suffer in her place.

"...so, we should be able to hack into the government's database easily once we get access to their systems. But we can't do that from outside; we need access to a terminal or the main server. That's very inconvenient - the Iranians really need to upgrade their computer systems!" Entrapta said.

"I think making it harder to hack into their data banks is the point for them," Bow commented.

"But it's also very inefficient! They might have to use crystals - sorry, compact discs, I think, right? - to transfer data. And that makes it easy to lose data. One missing disc, or one mistake, and you have two different sets of data in two computers," Entrapta retorted. "And you won't be able to know which one is correct. We might save the wrong people - not that would be a bad thing - but we might miss out on someone we want to save if the Iranians didn't keep their data up to date."

"They might deliberately fudge the data - or lose it - to hide their crimes," Sam pointed out.

“I thought the government wanted their prisoners tortured,” Entrapta said, blinking. “Why would they hide that? That makes checking if people are following your orders much harder.”

“Because officially, they aren’t torturing people in Iran,” Sam said.

“They absolutely do,” Bow disagreed. “They beat, mutilate and *stone* people.”

“Yes, they do.” Sam nodded. “But those are official punishments. Torturing prisoners to get confessions, or just to harm them, is supposed to be illegal in Iran.” Even though everyone knew it happened. As it did in most countries in the Middle East. And, Sam added with a guilty feeling, in some cases in the United States. At least in America, the culprits would be prosecuted, not protected and promoted. If they were caught, of course. And were not working for the NID or CIA.

“So, they are breaking their own rules and laws. And that makes it harder for us to help people.” Entrapta pouted.

“Yes,” Sam said. “If we have to access their computers directly, we need to enter the building where their main data banks are housed.”

“Well, someone has to,” Bow said. “Not all of us need to go. The rest of us can work remotely.”

“But someone has to guard the one inside, so we need more people with them,” Entrapta pointed out. “Like when I was hacking Horde Prime’s system. Systems.”

Like the rest of SG-1 guarding her. But she wouldn’t be going on this mission, Sam reminded herself.

“We could send in a bot,” Entrapta said. “One to access the data banks, and maybe a few more to guard them?”

“And ensure that no technology can be recovered, should things go wrong,” Sam added.

“Right, that too. We could build a bot for this! A hacking bot! Like a spy bot, but with all sorts of connections for computers!” Entrapta beamed.

Sam frowned a little. “Maybe make it modular? There are a lot of possible computer connections on Earth alone.” And every new standard added another because people kept old and obsolete systems going.

“Or make it adaptable?” Bow suggested. “So it can reconfigure itself to access a wider range of systems?”

“Yes! Or a combination of both!” Entrapta nodded. “Let’s start designing it!”

Sam nodded. This should be a nice engineering challenge. A nice change of pace from genetic engineering. Just what she needed on this particular date.

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“Valentine’s Day?”

Catra nodded. “Yes. It’s an Earth holiday for couples. Worldwide.” Well, at least according to the media she had checked. Which were rather America-centric. Anyway, it was still close enough. “It’s celebrated by exchanging chocolate or flowers and going on a date.”

“Oh. A holiday for couples…” Adora trailed off. Then her eyes widened. “I completely missed it! I didn’t prepare anything!” She jumped up from her chair, almost knocking into her desk in their quarters on Darla.

“Well, I didn’t.” Catra grinned and pulled the box of chocolates she’d had Daniel purchase for them out of her bag. “Here!”

Adora glanced at it, then bit her lower lip. “But I didn’t get you anything!”

You've given me more than enough, Catra thought. Far more than I deserve. Out loud, she said: "You can make it up to me later." She grinned at her lover's blush. "I also prepared a date for us. And you can make up for that later as well," she added when Adora opened her mouth.

"But… why didn't you tell me?"

"You were busy planning the largest prison break in history," Catra said, making a point of shrugging. And a mental note to rub that in Sea Hawk's face the next time he started boasting about his adventures.

"So were you!" And here came the pout she knew so well.

"But you're the Supreme Commander of the Alliance. You have so much else to do, I didn't want to distract you." And Adora would have probably tried to stop the whole thing because she would feel guilty about taking time off for herself (and Catra) while people were suffering in Iranian prisons. Even though they couldn't really do anything until Entrapta and the others finished building their new bot.

"You actually went on a recon mission for it!" Adora retorted. "That was very distracting!"

"Distracting, you say?" Catra grinned again, then moved forward until their noses were almost touching. "Like this!"

Adora pressed her lips together and raised her chin a little. "Yes! I mean, not exactly like this - but also distracting!"

"Good." Catra raised her hand and put her palm on Adora's cheek then moved it forward, to the back of her lover's head, gently gripping her hair, before starting to pull Adora's face towards her own and…

"There you are! Are you ready for Valentine's Day?"

Catra turned around and hissed at Glimmer. “Don’t barge into our room!”

“Oh, was I interrupting something?” Glimmer blinked. “You weren’t about to have sex so close before our dates?”

“Dates?” Adora asked.

“Yes, it’s Valentine’s Day!” Glimmer nodded. “A traditional date for a date.”

“You knew about that as well? And you didn’t tell me?” Adora frowned.

“Catra said she wanted to surprise you. And you were stressing yourself enough already with the mission planning,” Glimmer said.

Adora pouted at her, then at Catra.

“See? We know you best.” Catra patted her lover’s head, but Adora pulled away before she could mess up the poof.

“Wait! You said ‘our dates’?”

“Yes. Bow and me, and you and Catra, of course,” Glimmer said.

Catra nodded.

“So, this is going to be a double date?” Adora asked.

“No!” Catra said at once.

“No.” Glimmer shook her head. “Traditionally, it’s just the couple. We’re going on separate dates. Just in the same city, so we don’t have to take two shuttles.”

And so we’re close - relatively - if something happens, Catra mentally added.

“Ah.” Adora nodded. “That makes sense.”

She seemed relieved - had she honestly thought they'd go on a double date? Catra snorted.

"So, where are we going?"

"There's only one location that is perfect for this holiday," Glimmer replied. "The City of Love!"

"Paris," Catra explained when she saw Adora didn't recognise the name.

"That's the City of Love?"

"Yes. It's supposed to be the most romantic city on Earth," Glimmer said. "It's famous for it!"

"And it's the capital of France," Catra added. "One of our first Earth allies." So they should be safe enough there.

Adora muttered: "I know that."

"Good! Now get ready - we'll be leaving in thirty minutes!" Glimmer told them before storming out of the room. "I'll have to drag Bow out of the lab and get him presentable!"

"Isn't Bow helping Sam and Entrapta build a new bot?" Adora asked.

"I am sure they can spare him for the rest of the day," Catra told her. If not - tough!

"I know Sam's not going to go on a date, what with all the regulations," Adora said. "But maybe Entrapta would like to go on a date as well?" It doesn't seem fair if we go on a date and leave her to work."

"We talked about dates with her," Catra said.

"Oh? What did she say?"

“Well, as she sees it, you go on a date to have fun,” Catra said. “And she said she had the most fun doing science.”

“Oh, but…” Adora trailed off.

“She also mentioned experimenting with Hordak,” Catra added.

“Oh. But did she mean…?” Adora trailed off, blushing a little.

“Yes,” Catra said. Their friend had been as blunt and informative as always. “Anyway, let’s go change for our date.”

“Right!” Adora nodded. “We can’t be late! That would ruin the schedule!”

Catra snorted. As if she would plan a date like Adora would!

“What?”

“Nothing. Go change,” Catra said. “Pick the white dress.”

“I don’t have a white dress.”

“Yes, you do.” Catra grinned again. “You can repay me later.”

“I will!” Adora nodded, then suddenly smiled almost mischievously. “But first…” Two steps brought her face to face with Catra again.

This time, their kiss wasn’t interrupted.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 14th, 1999

Working on a Sunday. And on Valentine’s Day, to boot. Well, they were at war - now also officially - and it wasn’t as if Jack O’Neill had something planned for the weekend. Or Valentine’s Day. Especially since Carter - since the rest of SG-1, he corrected himself - was a bunch of workaholics whose idea of a good

weekend was doing research. Except for Teal'c, who liked to train and meditate. And watch Star Wars. Or other movies or TV shows that caught his interest. Which wouldn't actually be a bad way to spend the Sunday.

"So, the Etherians are going through with their plans."

Right, he was in the middle of a briefing. "Yes, sir," he told the Secretary of Defense.

"You couldn't convince them not to invade a sovereign country."

"They're not planning an invasion or intervention, sir," he corrected the man. "They're planning a prison break. A covert action. And I couldn't convince them that they should leave those people to be tortured at the hand of an evil regime," he added before he could help himself. He managed to keep a bland expression on his face, at least. Just quoting official policy.

"The world will see it as an intervention!" The Secretary of Defense shook his head. "And do you know how many countries will fear they will be next?"

How many countries persecute sorceresses and torture their political prisoners? Jack knew better than to say that, of course. "I think that's a question for the Secretary of State, not for the military."

Judging by the scowl that caused on the other man's face, that wasn't the right answer, either.

"How to react to the dangers and threats this will cause is a question for the military!"

Jack was sure the military had plans for every such threat or danger. Hell, they had plans for an attack by or on Canada! And it wasn't Stargate Command's problem. He almost snorted when he thought that most threats from those countries could probably be handled by the Coasties. Especially if they could use advanced scanners.

“But that isn’t your problem. Dismissed.”

Jack nodded, stood and left the room.

Outside, he checked his watch. The briefing hadn’t run as long as he had thought. It hadn’t even run as long as it had been supposed to. So, while he technically should go back to his office and do more paperwork, no one would actually expect him to be available for a good while longer. And as a veteran soldier, Jack knew how to act in this situation.

He grinned as he started towards the lift to the upper levels. If he tried to take a break in the mess hall, someone would come and bother him. Same for his office. But outside? He could always claim he was doing a surprise inspection of the training grounds. No one could argue that - well, no one who could argue that would likely be outside the mountain. And a bit of fresh air would do him good as well.

He grinned as he pushed the button of the lift. He was lucky - he could hear it coming to a stop right away!

“Ah, hello, Colonel.” Lenkova was inside the cabin, dressed for the field.

He managed to smile and nod without tensing up. “Lieutenant. Training on Sunday?”

“Yes.” She nodded curtly. Professionally. A moment passed. Just as he thought this would be an awkward ride, she added: “You as well? Or are you going home? Or to a meeting in space?”

“I thought I’d inspect the troops training today,” Jack replied before realising that sticking with his cover story meant he would have to actually do it. He couldn’t get lost on the way with Lenkova in tow.

She nodded again. “You shouldn’t find anything amiss with my team.”

“I don’t expect it either,” he said. It was true - Lenkova had run her reformed team even harder than her old one since she was cleared for service again.

She smiled in response. Almost shyly, he thought. Not like the confident, even flirty smile she had before she had been taken over by a snake.

Damn the Goa’uld.

They reached the first stop and travelled to the lift that led up to the surface. There were only American guards here, of course; this was no longer Stargate Command turf. “Are you looking forward to the move?” he asked as they entered the second cabin. “To Canada.”

“I think having a base dedicated to Stargate Command, and in a more accessible location, is a good idea.”

“That’s almost word for word the official stance,” he told her, raising his eyebrows.

Another small smile. “I kind of liked it here. Some of the changes I don’t like.”

Was that about the climate? Or was she subtly referring to the reassignment of SG-1 that everyone knew would be coming? Or was Jack seeing things? She’s still recovering from Goa’uld possession, he reminded himself. Of course, so, technically, was Carter.

He pushed the thoughts away. Time t focus on work. “So, any insight into today’s training?” he asked.

“It’s a basic assault and close combat drill,” she said.

“The basics are important,” he commented.

“Of course, sir.”

They talked shop until they reached the training area.

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Paris, France, Earth, February 14th, 1999

"You can't go to Paris and not visit the Eiffel Tower!"

Adora looked at the tower. It was impressive enough, with all those huge steel beams and rails and other things. They didn't have anything like it on Etheria. Some of the factory complexes in the former Fright Zone, maybe… No. But Catra sounded a bit too enthusiastic. "Really?" Adora asked. Glimmer and Bow weren't with them, after all.

Catra nodded. "Everyone says so. At least according to what I've read. Just look at it! There's none of that glittering glass that covers most skyscrapers. And there aren't any offices or flats in it. This tower was built for only one purpose: So you can climb it and watch the world from its top! And it's perfect for that!" She smiled widely. "No stench of factories, no pipes releasing smoke or steam, no stupid cheap walls blocking the sight. Just you and the fresh air and the sun!" She beamed at Adora.

Adora smiled back. This did take them back to their cadet days. Catra had loved to climb on the tallest structures in the Fright Zone, and… Oh. She winced a little.

Catra frowned at her. "What?"

"I don't think you're allowed to *climb* it," Adora said, pointing at a sign ahead of them.

"What?" Catra checked her pamphlet. "They talk about climbing it on foot here!"

"That probably means taking the stairs, not scaling the… beams," Adora replied.

“But… You’re right - there aren’t any other climbers. So much for it being perfect!” Catra muttered.

Adora wrapped her arm around her waist. “It will still have a great view, and we can walk up the stairs.”

“It’s not the same…”

Her lover eyed the tower again. Then the guards on the ground.

There were more of them than Adora had expected, she noted. But she also noticed the expression on Catra’s face. “Don’t try climbing it anyway,” she said.

“I bet we could dodge the guards. They wouldn’t try to stop the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, would they?”

“We’re on a date,” Adora pointed out.

Catra pouted some more, then sighed. “It would have been fun… But let’s take the lift then. It’ll be faster.”

“And it will be easier on the guards,” Adora added. She glanced at the not-so-subtle French guards that had been shadowing them ever since they had stepped out of the car that had taken them here from their shuttle at the airport. They were easy to spot since, unlike the passers-by, they were not gawking at her and Catra and taking pictures. The guards were looking at everyone other than them.

“That would be a reason to take the stairs and watch them struggle.” Catra grinned. “But it would take too long, I think.”

“Longer than it would have taken you to climb the tower?” Adora raised her eyebrows.

“It’s not the same!” Catra retorted. “Let’s go!”

As they approached the tower’s base, Adora noticed the guards moving the other people waiting there away. Or trying to - the

people didn't want to move. Well, that was understandable. Adora wouldn't like having to move either if she had been waiting. And this was all because of Catra and her date!

Then she realised that the people weren't trying to keep their spot in the queue - they were trying to get closer to her and Catra. "Uh. Maybe we should have gone, ah, 'incognito'…" That was the Earth term for going in disguise; she remembered Glimmer mentioning it.

"And how would I have been able to disguise myself? Crush my ears and use my tail as a belt?" Catra scoffed. "Besides, I want to go on a date with you. As we are. I'm not going to hide!"

Ah… Adora smiled at her and pulled her a bit closer into her side. She felt Catra's tail rub along her calf and thigh and her ear tickle Adora's neck when her lover leaned into her.

Which made the crowd ahead - and around them - break out on cheers. Loud cheers. And demands for autographs. And other things Adora didn't quite understand.

By the time they reached the lift, Adora didn't feel guilty about everyone else being pushed back any more.

Catra was scowling at her datapad as the lift carried them up the tower. "I think I have to adjust our planned date. Obviously, taking a stroll down Les Champs-Elysées isn't going to be very romantic if we get mobbed like this."

Adora nodded. "The restaurant should be fine, though."

Her lover nodded. "But some of the other spots… We'll have to improvise," she said with a grin.

Adora nodded again.

The view from the top of the tower was breathtaking. Somehow, seeing Paris sprawling below them, the Seine running through endless lines and blocks of houses, showed just how many people

lived on Earth even better than watching the planet from orbit or a shuttle.

And Catra's kiss there was breathtaking as well.

"I don't like this," Catra commented five minutes later.

What? Adora blinked. This was perfect! The blue sky above them, the city below them, Catra next to her… Then she realised Catra was looking directly down.

Where, Adora saw as she leaned over the railing, a large crowd was gathering. And still growing. The guards had formed a line to keep the people back, she also noticed - and there were more guards and police as well.

"Oh."

"Yeah. I blame Glimmer for this," Catra said, shaking her head.

"What?" Adora stared at her. Glimmer wasn't even here!

"Yes." Catra smirked. "She's the queen - she should be used to dealing with crowds."

Adora snorted. "She and Bow went in disguise, didn't they?" Bow had even worn a shirt that covered his abs.

Catra scowled in return before sniffing. "Anyway, obviously, taking a walk is off. But we should be fine on the river."

"On the river?" Adora looked at the Seine.

"I've booked a boat for a trip," Catra said. "It's a more *comfortable* way to see the city. The parts of it at the river, at least," she added with a grin that showed her fangs.

"Right." Adora nodded. Then her eyes widened, and her cheeks flushed when she realised what her lover meant. "Catra!"

"What?" Catra was smirking again. "What are you thinking?"

Oh, you! Adora pouted. “Tease.”

“Yes!” Catra held her gaze for a moment, then looked down at the ground again. “But first, we need to reach the river. I don’t think the humans down there will let us leave.”

Adora agreed. Some of the people were carrying placards and signs. “It looks like a protest - well, some of them do look like they’re protesting.”

“The French are famous for their protests,” Catra said. “Remember their riots when we arrived?”

Everyone had been rioting back then. Or so it had seemed. Adora made a neutral noise.

“Anyway. If we go down there, we’ll probably start a riot,” Cara went on. “Well, you would.”

“I would?” Adora frowned.

“You’re the princess.” Catra smirked.

“And you’re the *catgirl*,” Adora shot back.

“I’d just claw the first fool who tries to pull on my ears or tail. You’d have to deal with half the crowd begging you to heal them.”

Healing? Adora looked down again, squinting. Maybe not all of those signs were protesting her presence? Maybe they were cries for help?

“Oh, no! I know that look! We’re not here to heal everyone!” Catra hissed. “If you start, you won’t be able to stop. And you’ll cause a riot! We’re on a date, not a healing tour!”

“But… A healing tour?” Adora blinked.

“Forget about that as well!” Catra shook her head. “You’re the Supreme Commander of the Alliance. You don’t have time to go

heal people. We went over that, remember?”

Adora pressed her lips together. Yes, they had thought this out. She couldn’t heal everyone. Or even most. And she did have other duties.

“I won’t let you sacrifice your life for healing.”

“It wouldn’t…” Adora trailed off at Catra’s glare.

“Yes, it would cost you your life because I would kill you for trying!”

Adora doubted that. But… Catra did look… not quite desperate but very determined. And concerned, maybe afraid - she was trying to hide it, but Adora knew her. Just as Adora knew that Catra would be hurt if Adora was an idiot about this.

And she wouldn’t hurt Catra.

“I’m not going to heal those people,” she told her lover. Catra still looked sceptical, so Adora added: “If I do, people will expect me to heal them if they show up. We wouldn’t ever have some peace in public.”

Catra slowly nodded, then smiled and pulled her in for another kiss.

“We still need a way to leave the tower and get to the river without dragging half of Paris with us, though,” Adora pointed out once they broke their kiss.

“Oh, I’ll just call our stealth shuttle.”

“But we took a normal shuttle…” Adora blinked. “You’re going to call one from the fleet? We’ll have to ask the French for permission to enter their airspace.”

Catra smirked again.

Adora sighed. “It’s already here, over Paris, right?”

“We told the French that we’d help secure the airspace. They didn’t ask for details after we parked a frigate in orbit over Paris.” Catra flashed her fangs. She peered over the railing again. Adora followed her example. The crowd was still growing. “Besides, I don’t think they’ll mind if we say we’ll evacuate from the tower without going down.”

“Maybe we should at least talk to them,” Adora said. “If we just sneak away, they’ll be disappointed and angry…”

Catra scoffed. “So? They’ll be angry anyway once they’ll realise that you won’t spend your day healing them.”

That was true. Still… “But we should at least explain that we’re on a date here.” Adora nodded. Honesty was best. And that would avoid the French discovering that Catra sneaked a stealth shuttle into their airspace.

Catra sighed. “Don’t say I didn’t warn you.”

Adora smiled. “I’ll just explain things to them. It’ll be fine.”

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The boat - a bateau-mouche, whatever that meant - was travelling past a beautiful riverfront. All those pretty buildings… And the bridges. And the landmarks.

But Adora and Catra were the only ones looking at the riverfront. The other passengers on the boat were either looking at them.

Or at the smoke rising from the direction of the Eiffel Tower. Smoke mixed with tear gas.

“Told you so.”

Adora winced.

*****

Prison Break Part 3

Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 15th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and the so-called Valentine's Day Riots in Paris, France, are quieting down after a night full of violence that saw several hundred people arrested and dozens hurt. What damage has been caused remains unclear as of now; according to the authorities, they are still tallying the damage done during the riot. Although the mayor of Paris did confirm that, contrary to first reports, the Eiffel Tower wasn't damaged in the riots. The smoke that gave that impression originated from trash containers that were set on fire and rolled towards the police guarding the tower. Our correspondent is in Paris right now, reporting live from the Champs Elysées. Frank?"

The picture on the screen in the mess on board of Darla switched from the news studio to a man standing in the middle of a street in Paris.

"Thank you, John. Yes, the rioters have been dispersed, but the situation remains tense. Most people I have spoken with say that another riot could start at any moment for any reason. Inflammatory rumours are spreading, the most prominent amongst them that Princess She-Ra has refused to heal the rioters who were wounded in clashes with the police. So far, that has not been confirmed - but we did receive confirmation that the rioters who were released from medical care because they only suffered light wounds were not healed by her, which has fueled the rumours."

Samantha Carter shook her head but didn't comment as she glanced at the others at the table.

"Don't they understand that if Adora healed the wounded rioters, that would only make the next bunch hurt themselves to get healing?" Catra scoffed.

“But… Oh, you mean, they would slightly hurt themselves so Adora would heal their wounds and whatever medical condition they wanted healed, right?” Entrapta asked.

“Yes. But I wouldn’t put it past those morons to accidentally hurt themselves much more seriously. Or kill themselves.” Catra sneered as she reached for another bread roll.

Sam agreed, but she also understood that desperate people were not entirely rational. Not that she was about to mention that - Adora already looked like she felt this was all her fault. Even though the date in Paris had been Glimmer and Catra’s idea, according to Entrapta.

“Yes.” Glimmer scowled. “We had to skip half the locations I wanted to visit on our date!”

“It was still a great date,” Bow assured her with a smile.

Glimmer immediately beamed at him. “Thank you, Bow!” And then she frowned once more. “But it could have been even better!”

“Don’t complain. You at least weren’t limited to a boat and a restaurant - both surrounded by half a company of soldiers,” Catra said.

“Well, if you had disguised yourselves…” Glimmer trailed off.

“We decided against it,” Adora said. “We shouldn’t have to hide what we are or who we are.”

That was a great stance - in theory. In practice, there were obvious problems with it, in Sam’s opinion.

“But I shouldn’t have tried to talk to them,” Adora went on, looking morose.

“It wasn’t your fault that the morons didn’t listen,” Glimmer told her.

Catra cleared her throat. “Well, the French should have been better at dealing with the riot. They have those regularly, after all. That things went out of control like that…” She shook her head. “That’s on them.”

Adora didn’t look convinced but slowly nodded.

“At least we know now that we can’t visit Earth without wearing disguises,” Glimmer said. “So, next time shouldn’t see so much…” She looked at the screen and shrugged. “... trouble.”

“Easy for you to say,” Catra said. “I can’t just dye my hair, wear shades and Earth clothes and get mistaken for a human.”

“Well, you could wear a hat…” Bow trailed off and ducked his head a little when Catra glared at him.

“And shave off my fur and cut off my tail?”

“Right. Maybe we should look into a magitech holographic projector,” Bow said. “That way, you’d look like a human - any human - until someone tried to touch you.”

Sam nodded. They had looked into that while waiting for the latest results from their bot testing.

Catra scoffed. “And my tail?”

“Well…” Bow winced. “It could be disguised as a belt, I guess, but that would probably look weird.

“A belt!” Catra hissed.

“Just wrap it around your waist or stuff it down your trousers,” Glimmer said.

“We could try to build a tail-hide generator!” Entrapta piped up. “Maybe with a stealth system that only works on the tail! Or a dimensional extender that would look flat from the outside but

open on the inside so your tail would be in a pocket dimension, invisible to everyone!"

That sounded like… a huge effort for what was essentially just a question of convenience, in Sam's opinion. And what would happen if that contraption failed with the tail stuck inside? "I think a conventional disguise would be more efficient," she said.

"You mean, wrap the tail around your waist or stuff it down your trousers?" Entrapta asked.

Sam nodded.

Catra scowled, and Entrapta pouted. "That doesn't sound like fun," Sam's friend said.

"It's not fun at all!" Catra agreed. "Tying my tail up?" She shuddered.

If the Colonel had been here, he'd have a field day with such a comment, Sam knew. But he was stuck with paperwork he should have completed yesterday. Which served him right - according to scuttlebutt, he had gone training with Lenkova instead.

She pressed her lips together. The Colonel wouldn't have done anything untoward; she was certain. Still…

A beep from Entrapta's tool interrupted her thoughts. "Oh! The first batch of test models is finished!" She jumped up, propelled by her hair. "It's time for science! And testing!"

Ah, finally! Sam smiled as she got up as well. The Etherians could sort out their problems with visiting Earth themselves.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra watched the feed from the new bot. It wasn't really sneaky, in her opinion. Not graceful enough for its size. And not smart enough to pick the best routes and time its exposure - though that could be fixed by taking direct control, she supposed. But it wasn't agile enough to take advantage of the best hiding spots. And being able to fly could only make up for so much, even when the enemy couldn't detect the spell. But it might be enough to fool the Iranians. Maybe.

"Good bot!" Entrapta crowed. She pushed a button, and the feed from the bot shrank, replaced by a rapidly growing feed from a camera observing the testing area. Which was a frigate from Third Fleet.

"So far, no one seems to have noticed it," Bow said. "Which is a good thing for the bot but kind of a bad thing for our own security."

"Priest won't like it," Catra agreed. "He'll have to train his people better." Goa'uld didn't use spy bots - at least as far as she knew - but they could possess animals small enough to sneak around. At least long enough to get to an isolated crew member. And once they controlled a crew member… She clenched her teeth.

"He will," Adora said. "He's watching this."

They shared the feed with his flagship. They didn't leave a channel open, of course - no one wants Priest to praise Adora in the middle of a test. The official excuse was that the rest of the fleet, including his flagship's crew, wasn't supposed to know about this. A test for the bot and the clones, or a double-test, as Entrapta had called it.

"It still hasn't reached the computer core," Catra pointed out.

"Yes. Hacker-4 has to cross the main corridor for that - and descend to the auxiliary bridge," Entrapta said. "But I believe in it!"

Hacker-1 to 3 had not survived the destructive testing and the vacuum travel, respectively. The latter wasn't exactly a requirement for a mission on Earth, of course. But Entrapta and the others were planning ahead.

On the screen, the bot stopped in a corner of the main hallway. A pair of clones passed, chatting about… The Holy Dogma? Catra glanced at her lover, who was frowning deeply. Catra had expected that, though, if she was honest, Earth would be a much better place if everyone converted to the worship of She-Ra. Priest and his people might be fanatics, but at least they tried to follow Adora's example. And they didn't want to torture and kill everyone with magic.

She clenched her teeth. She knew how it felt to be tortured. No one should go through that. Well, with a few exceptions, maybe - but they were dead already.

"And it's down in the central maintenance shaft!" Entrapta announced. "Now all that's left is to get to the main databanks and access them. Go, Hacker-4!"

And that didn't take the bot long - the camouflage field wasn't very good, it couldn't hold a candle to Melog's illusions, but it was, obviously, good enough to fool a casual glance. Though would it be good enough to fool a bunch of guards expecting magical attacks?

Catra had her doubts. She and Melog could do this much more safely. But, she added with a glance at her lover, Adora would hate it.

Yes.

Catra glanced at Melog. They looked at her, then sat down and stretched, yawning. They knew her so well. And together, they could run rings around the Iranians - well, unless they posted dogs at every corner. If Melog had come with them on their date,

they could have walked past half the people in Paris without getting spotted.

But that wouldn't have been a date. A date was you and your lover. Or your lovers. Not you, your lover or lovers, and someone following you and watching everything you did. That was… creepy. Even if it was Melog who was watching. Especially if it was Melog, since they were a friend and not a faceless guard.

"So, that looks promising," Bow said.

"Not for that frigate's crew," Catra said with a snort.

"Catra!"

"What? It's the truth. We need better internal security." Catra shrugged. "Anway, that was a good first test, but we can't count on that working in the heart of the Iranian government. They'll expect spies and saboteurs." Such regimes always did. Often with good reasons.

"Well, we could test it on Stargate Command next!" Entrapta suggested.

"Ah… I think that wouldn't be a good idea," Sam said.

"Why not? They should have the best security on Earth right now. If Hacker-4 can infiltrate them, it can infiltrate anyone!"

Catra snorted. It would be fun. But it was too dangerous. "We would have to inform the Command Council first - and some of them might leak the information to warn the Iranians," she said.

"Why would they do that?" Entrapta asked. "Some of them are our allies, and the others are working closely with our allies."

"That's…" Sam winced. "That doesn't mean everyone in their governments can be trusted."

Or that their governments could be trusted, Catra thought. Officially, Russia and China were still planning to join the Alliance, but they hadn't really been pressing for serious negotiations lately.

Which was suspicious, in her opinion.

"Oh!" Entrapta shook her head. "But… Oh! Can we do it in the Pentagon, then? We can trust our allies, right? And you complained about the Pentagon before, Sam."

"Ah…" Sam winced again. "That wouldn't be a good idea, either."

And Catra chuckled.

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Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 17th, 1999

"So… you managed to convince the mad scientist princess that using the Pentagon to test your new bot and using your new bot to test the Pentagon's security at the same time was a bad idea." Jack O'Neill didn't know if he should grin or groan at the news. He should have expected such a proposal from Entrapta, of course - the woman had a bit of tunnel vision.

"Yes, sir." Carter, professional as always, nodded. Even though this wasn't a formal briefing - SG-1 was just meeting in her lab. Coincidentally, if anyone asked. And of anyone asked what they were doing, they were watching the news on the screen in the back of her lab. Which was a mix of 'news' from France, people reacting to the riots, and some entitled idiots claiming it was all She-Ra's fault for not healing everyone. And some useless motion in the United Nations to stop witch hunts, which all the countries doing witch hunting would ignore - and decry it as colonialism or something.

"Why would it be a bad idea, actually?" Daniel asked with a frown. "It would be useful to see how good security is, wouldn't it? And if

the bot can hack the Pentagon's computer, it should be able to hack the Iranian government's computer as well."

"That's not correct," Carter said, frowning as well. "We did install adaptive hacking routines, but since computer architecture varies a lot - although basic principles remain the same, and many routines build on each other - you could have a hacking routine that can defeat the defences of the Pentagon, but not an outdated exotic operating system still in use in Iran. It is unlikely, though," she added.

Daniel nodded. "It would still be a good test, though, for both."

"Yes," Carter said. "But it would also likely cause resentment."

Now their friend looked puzzled. "But not if they ask for permission beforehand. They would ask, right?"

"Of course," Carter confirmed, to Jack's relief. "But in order to test the Pentagon's defences, the staff there wouldn't be informed. And should they fail to defeat the bot's infiltration attempt, which seems likely based on my calculations, the careers of key personnel could end up affected."

"And unless someone *really* messes up, they won't be cashiered but could very well end up in a dead-end position," Jack added. "And some will hold a grudge over that and still have enough influence to take revenge." Petty, probably, and pointless, but enough to ruin other careers - or even missions.

"Oh."

"Such behaviour is common amongst the false gods," Teal'c added with a slow nod. He was talking in an even tone, as if he were commenting on the weather, but it was still one of the strongest condemnations of such officers that Jack had heard in a while.

"Still… wouldn't it be better if any weakness in our security would be revealed before the war picks up steam?" Daniel asked. "And officers who, ah, don't measure up?"

“Yep,” Jack told him. “Like a shakedown cruise. Shake up the whole organisation.”

His friend blinked. “But…?”

“But such things rarely end well for the one doing the shaking up,” Jack explained. “People take such things personally.” The Etherians had already - often without intending to - stepped on too many toes of too many self-important people. And nations.

“Ah.” Daniel nodded - he would be familiar with that attitude from his own field. The fact that he hadn’t used his very public vindication to settle a few old grudges showed that he just was too good for his field, in Jack’s opinion.

“And someone in the government might be tempted to leak news of the ‘test’ to make his friends and proteges look good,” Jack said.

“You have a rather low opinion of our government and the Pentagon, Jack,” Daniel commented.

“I have a lot of experience with both,” Jack retorted.

“Corruption is another trait common amongst the false gods.”

“I still think it shouldn’t be too bad,” Daniel said, pouting some more. “And it might save lives. We’re at war! And would such an officer really dare provoke the Etherians with some petty revenge?”

Shaking out the incompetent officers in the Pentagon and elsewhere before they led troops into combat or planned missions would definitely save lives. But… Jack sighed. “We can’t just rely on the Etherians as a big stick to get our way. People might get used to it.” Sooner or later, everyone - on Earth and Etheria - would internalise that.

“And would that be a bad thing?” Daniel asked.

"Many people will feel oppressed even if the Etherians only want the best for everyone. And Operation Jailbreak won't help with that impression. The Etherians announced - months ago - that they would intervene if there's a genocide," he went on, "but I don't think everyone realised that they actually mean it." The Iranians certainly hadn't. But once the rest of the world understood that the Etherians would intervene, the reactions wouldn't be pretty.

Russia and China might attempt to use that as well to gain more influence in the United Nations. But would they stop trying to join the Alliance? NATO was doing all they could without being obvious to block them, Jack had heard from old colleagues stationed at Brussels, and at least China might very well decide that having to use spies to get advanced technology and lagging a bit behind the curve was worth if it meant the party would keep control over their population, especially the soldiers. On the other hand, if they decided that the Etherians would soon intervene in their countries anyway because of their treatment of various minorities, things wouldn't be pretty. Not at all.

But there was no stopping the Etherians from doing what they thought was the right thing.

Something that most governments, including the United States', would find horrific.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Adora sighed as she watched Earth through the windows of Darla's bridge.

"Are you still feeling guilty for the riots?" Catra was standing behind her, and Adora didn't have to turn around - or look at her reflection in the glass - to know her lover was frowning at her.

"I don't," Adora said. It wasn't entirely her fault, at least, so it wasn't a complete lie.

Catra sniffed in response. "It's not your fault. If the French riot, that's on them."

"But if we had been disguised, we could've had a nice date as planned," Adora said. "It was nice enough, I mean, given, ah, everything…" She winced as she turned around.

Catra snorted. "That wasn't your fault either. I should have expected that. We should have gone to Etheria for a date."

That wasn't right, either. "That would be like hiding," Adora said.

"It wouldn't be the same as hiding - it would be more like avoiding a minefield. Or a choke point," Catra retorted.

"An allied country shouldn't be a minefield," Adora pointed out. They should be able to go out in an allied country, shouldn't they?

"I think their president can't go out without guards either," Catra said.

"But he doesn't start riots." Adora thought he wouldn't, at least.

"And the famous people on Earth have to deal with people annoying them on dates as well," Catra said. "So, it's not your fault. It's just how humans here act."

"I haven't heard of a riot being started over autographs," Adora pointed out.

"They probably hid that." Catra grinned. "Anyway, we might get a working disguise for next time."

"Next Valentine's Day?" Adora asked with a grin.

"By then, whatever Entrapta and Sam will have built can probably hide an entire company on the Champs Elysées. Including tanks."

Catra snorted.

Adora laughed as well, but… it was probably not too much hyperbole. They - and Bow, and Hordak - had been working a few days on the hacking bots, and the latest model could already turn almost invisible. Sam had called it a 'predator mode' and then had begged them not to tell Jack she had said that. Unfortunately, the bot couldn't maintain that mode for too long. But it should be enough to hack the Iranians - thanks to the magic scanner, they had the building mapped out perfectly, down to the server storage room. And the shuttles were ready as well. Tonight - well, according to Iranian time - they could launch their mission.

But until then… "Melog could do that," she said. Their friend was a master of illusion magic.

Catra nodded. "But I don't want to ask him to disguise us for a date. That wouldn't be fair."

"I don't think they'd mind," Adora said. Melog adored Catra… She blinked. Good thing she hadn't said that out loud - Catra would tease her about her involuntary pun, and once she told Jack…

"It would also feel a bit weird having them shadow us for the entire date," Catra said.

"We had a dozen French guards shadow us for our entire date." Catra had pointed them out to Adora.

"That's different," Catra said. "They're doing what they were ordered to. Melog's our friend. And they can feel my emotions," she added in a lower voice. While not looking at Adora.

Oh. That was the reason, then, for Catra's refusal to ask Melog for help.

"I don't mind, not really," Catra said, still not looking at her. "It's nice to know they like me, despite knowing me so well."

Adroa almost rolled her eyes. Instead, she hugged her lover.

Catra squirmed a little, but not seriously. “But having a date like that…”

Adora nodded, then let her chin rest on Catra’s shoulder. Melog would be invisible, but there was no need to point that out. If Catra was uncomfortable with Melog following them on a date, then Adora would accept that.

“The date was still fun,” she said.

“Could’ve been better, though.”

“Most dates could’ve been better, I think. No one’s perfect.” Adora hugged her a bit more tightly. “And we didn’t ruin Glimmer and Bow’s date.”

“They complained as if we had,” Catra said. “Glimmer, at least.”

“She was hoping to climb the Eiffel Tower with Bow once we were done there,” Adora said. Her friend had told her that a visit there was a must, after all.

Catra snorted. “Tough luck. She could have teleported up there, anyway. No one could’ve stopped her.” She chuckled. “So, we had the better date.”

It wasn’t a competition. Although Glimmer and Catra might disagree, in Adora’s opinion. But that wasn’t important right now.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter was merely an observer. Not an active participant. That was perfectly acceptable according to international law. Military officers used to follow foreign armies as observers in wars where their country wasn’t a participant all the time in the past.

But regardless of how often she repeated the thought to herself, it rang hollow. No one would believe her, not with her close relationship with the Etherians known so well. Even if it was, technically, true - she was merely observing how the hacking bot was performing. Of course, she had helped design, build and test it, but that wasn't active participation in a conflict either. Technically. But no one would agree with that view.

"Alright! Everyone's in position!" Entrapta announced. "Do you have the readings, Sam?"

Not even the Etherians.

"I'm just observing, but yes," Sam told her. She ignored the snort from Catra.

On the holoprojector, she could see a live 3D projection of the target building in Tehran, with the internal structure and even the people inside overlaid on it.

"If we had that kind of intel, Eagle Claw… well, it would have still failed, but it wouldn't have been quite so foolhardy," the Colonel commented.

"I think we would have had better intel about the landing sites and the conditions as well," Sam pointed out.

"And we might have started a war," Daniel added. "That the operation failed allowed the Iranian government to save face."

Was that a subtle criticism of the Etherian plans? Sam couldn't quite tell - Daniel was in favour of freeing political prisoners.

"Well, if they want a war, we can give them a war," Catra said. "It won't be a long war, though."

"They would be stupid to start a war with us." Glimmer shook her head. "Since they haven't started a war with the United States in the past, I doubt they'll declare war on us over freeing their

abused prisoners. The risk that rival countries will exploit that should be obvious."

"Well, most of their neighbours don't like your policies either," the Colonel retorted.

"Well, it's not entirely impossible that the other countries in the region would support Iran, especially if they fear a similar intervention in their own territory, but there are a lot of old grudges and rivalries to consider," Daniel said.

"We've gone over this before," Adora said.

"And we're ready!" Entrapta pointed at the holoprojection. "The stealth shuttle is ready, Hacking-5 is all wired up, and Guard-4 and Guard-5 are ready as well!"

Sam checked the readings. Indeed, all three bots and the shuttle were ready inside Darla's hangar.

"Start the stealth system," Adora said.

On the screen to the side, the shuttle vanished from view. Since Darla was facing Earth, the ship didn't have to manoeuvre to hide the hangar doors opening, and the shuttle launched without any visible sign.

On the sensor screen, Sam could track how it broke orbit and started to enter the atmosphere. That was tricky, even with the advanced stealth system, but they had plotted the course so the shuttle was on the other side of the world from Iran when it did so.

"No reaction from any ground-based defences," Entrapta reported after a few minutes. That meant the defences of other countries, Sam knew - they were just approaching Iran now. "Shuttle - we really need a good name for her - is entering Iranian airspace… now!"

Sam tensed even though she knew that there was no indication that the Iranians could spot the shuttle. But as the flight path on the map updated, showing how it travelled towards Tehran, without any sign that the Iranian air force had detected it, she relaxed again.

A bit later, the shuttle hovered above the target building. And the few people inside the installation, guards and what looked like a janitor and some night shift technicians, at least according to the pattern of how they moved, hadn't shown any reaction at all.

Nor did they when the three bots launched, flying down to the roof, where the intakes of the air conditioning keeping the servers cool were installed. And the hatch leading down to the top floor of the building. In theory, the bots could enter through the air vents, but it would be a very tight fit, and they would have to go through several filters and deal with mesh wire and bars. With the hallways deserted except for the occasional patrol - which they could track with their scanner - the normal access was safer. And quicker.

Sam still almost bit her lower lip when the bots swept down, opened the hatch and entered the building proper.

"It's like a video game," the Colonel commented when the projections representing the bots travelled down the main stairs, headed toward the server room. "Just needs a few save points."

Sam narrowed her eyes at him - it wasn't a game! - but Daniel chuckled, as did Catra and Bow, despite Glimmer and Adora frowning at them.

Entrapta nodded. "We did use some video game interfaces for this - they were quite ergonomic."

Sam didn't blush when the Colonel grinned at her. She was still grateful that the hacking bot arrived at the server room right that moment, before the Colonel could tease her about video games,

and she could pretend to be focused on the hacking attempt. Observing only, of course.

Not that the bot needed her to interfere, anyway - Iranian computer security, once you had access to the physical server, was almost nonexistent. At least for people using advanced technology. And the same went for the physical security - looping the few cameras observing the hallway and the room was all it took to blind it.

A bit later - though it had taken longer than Sam had hoped to get the data because of the outdated computers used by the Iranians had very slow data transfer rates - all three bots were leaving the building again, with no one the wiser.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 19th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Alright, we've analysed the data! Sorry that it took so long, but it was really badly organised - I don't know how the Iranians were supposed to work with such an inefficient system! They can't trust their data at all! We had to infer most information from secondary sources like medical reports, and even there, they were using incorrect data. It was only through pattern analysis that we managed to filter out the truth. If they had simply used encryption, it would have been faster, I think. So, sorry, it really wasn't our fault. If we get the opportunity, we should upgrade their system."

Catra snorted at Entrapta's comment. Her friend sounded more annoyed than when she had started dealing with the Horde's logistics. "That was the point - they didn't want to leave proof of their crimes," she reminded her.

"It's still inefficient," her friend complained with a pout. "Anyway, we've got the people we need to save - all the ones suffering from torture and all the ones accused of magic - and we have marked

their locations. Though that needs to be confirmed before we can take them since this data might also not be true."

Catra nodded. That was a complication, but they had expected that.

"Ah, if only every murderous regime was as efficient with their paperwork as the Nazis were," O'Neill commented.

"They weren't actually as efficient as popular opinion claims, Jack," Daniel objected. "Although they were probably better at documenting their heinous acts than the Iranians, and…"

"...and it's not really relevant, Daniel."

"But…"

Adora cleared her throat. "So, we have the names, but we can't be sure that they are where they should be? I mean, they shouldn't be in prison, of course, but they should be in the cell that the data says… I mean… You know what I mean!"

Catra snickered. "Yes, we do."

"If we have to check everyone to see if they are who we think they are before taking them, then that will take too much time to pull this off and get away before reinforcements arrive at the prisons," Bow pointed out. "We need to check beforehand."

"We - you can do it with our scanner," Sam said. "Match the biometrics - at least the basic information like height - with the data we got. Pictures, if we can trust them."

It was funny how she tried to pretend she wasn't part of this operation. Catra would like to tease her about it, but this wasn't the time for that. "Yes, that sounds good," she said.

"That would reduce but probably not eliminate the risk of leaving someone behind," Entrapta said. "If they had DNA records… but

testing would be too long. Unless we build a bot that can take samples beforehand!”

“A robot mosquito?” O’Neill raised his eyebrows.

“That would probably be best,” Entrapta replied, obviously taking his comment as a serious suggestion. “We just need them to draw blood, after all, and flying would make that easy. Although they probably would be a bit bigger than a mosquito.”

“Robot vampire bat?”

“I thought vampires were fictional.” Entrapta blinked.

“It’s the name of a small flying mammal that consumes blood as part of its diet,” Sam explained.

“Ah.”

“I don’t think we should build another bot,” Glimmer said. “That will take more time, and we would need a lot of them to test every target. The risk that they would be spotted would be too great.”

Adora nodded - reluctantly; Catra could tell. “We’ll see how many are left when we’re done with that.”

“If we have to, we’ll just grab everyone who fits the data,” Catra said. “We can sort them out afterwards.”

Jack winced at that, but that was probably just envy that they couldn’t do that when he was doing that stuff on Earth.

Ah, well. She stretched. “So, there’s nothing we can do but wait until you’re done, right?” Catra said, grabbing Adora’s hand. “Then we’ll head to bed so we’re well-rested when you’re done,” she went on without waiting for an answer. “You can worry in bed,” she added in a lower voice, cutting off Adora’s protest.

Not that she would let her lover worry, of course. Not in bed, at least.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill hated staying safely behind while his people went into harm's way. Watching the Etherians prepare to launch Operation The Great Escape - it was a perfectly fine name, even if no one else except Jack wanted to use it - was the same kind of torture as watching another Stargate team prepare to go through a gate. Sure, he knew that the people on the teams were trained as well as possible and that the mission was supposed to be safe-ish - the hardest and most dangerous missions went to SG-1, after all - but he also knew that Murphy was just waiting to throw a spanner or two in the works and good people would get hurt or worse. And waiting for that call to action, to go in and get your friends out - or avenge them - was the worst. And with the increase in personnel, more people he had trained, this was bound to get worse at Stargate Command. Lenkova's last mission had been a perfect example of that.

But Jack had been able to save half the team and avenge the rest, at least. Eventually. The prison break was worse since he wasn't allowed to go in and help his friends should anything go wrong. The orders he had received had been very clear about that.

Damn politics. The Etherians were allies, and Iran was a hostile nation with a history of supporting terrorism. And this was about enforcing human rights. America should go all-in on this! Or at least send in SG-1 with the Etherians. Even Daniel would be on board for this. After some worrying about international law, at least.

But no, the Alliance didn't want to be seen invading other countries. Not unless it was a clear case of defending against an invasion. Or to stop a genocide that wasn't disputed by half the

United Nations. But even in the United States, some of the radio host nutcases were talking about witch hunts being justified.

It's a crazy world, he thought, looking down at the world in question below him while the comm channels picked on Darla's bridge.

"Stealth transport shuttles moving into assigned staging areas."

"If only we had the time to reconstruct Horde Prime's teleporter."

"Strike teams boarding the stealth commando shuttles."

'Strike teams' meant princesses, some of them younger than most marines at Stargate Command. One of them was still a bloody teenager!

Jack clenched his teeth at the thought. Magic didn't make you bulletproof - not unless you were She-Ra. Etherian body armour was good but not perfect. Nothing was perfect. A stray shot, a moment of bad luck… Not even She-Ra could raise the dead. Well, in theory, there were sarcophaguses, but… Jack shook his head.

All of the princesses had volunteered for this, he reminded himself. They knew the risks. But teenagers who weren't old enough to get a drink in most countries shouldn't be allowed to volunteer, sovereign heads of state or not! This was Earth, not Etheria.

But Jack wasn't calling the shots. The Etherians were. And they were perfectly fine with letting Frosta hit an Iranian prison. 'She's fought worse when she was younger', Glimmer had told him, as if that was an argument for letting her fight more!

But the Teleporting Terror clearly thought so, and the rest were backing her, even Adora and Catra, who should know better.

"Stealth Commando Shuttles launching."

He turned to glance at the projection on Darla's bridge. He couldn't see the shuttles with the naked eye, but the tracking sensors displayed their course as they spread out, entering the atmosphere on the opposite side of the world from Iran.

"They have thoroughly prepared this mission," Carter commented. "They have all the advantages, and we didn't find any sign of a trap."

Jack grunted in response. It would have been more reassuring if she hadn't been glued to the sensor readouts since this circus had started.

Carter didn't react. "Shuttles entering Iranian airspace," she announced a few minutes later. "Following set courses on schedule."

I can see that, Jack thought - he knew the courses set for the shuttles by heart. He had helped pick them. They avoided the known anti-air defences of the Iranians and were as safe as he could make them. Still, no plan was perfect. And no operation went perfectly according to plan. An unscheduled flight, a spontaneous exercise because an officer was feeling grumpy or ambitious, some civilian spotting a weird thing and overreacting or just plain mechanical failures… Missions had failed for any reason. Sometimes violently.

But there was still no reaction from the Iranians as the shuttles stopped above the prisons. No frantic scramble, no patrolling aircraft switching courses, no guns going off. Everything seemed to be going to plan.

And Jack had a bad feeling about this.

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Prison Break Part 4

Above Evin Prison, Tehran, Iran, Earth, February 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

From above, the Evin Prison didn't look like much. Adora had seen prefab camps that looked more solid. Which was deceptive; the walls were stable and sturdy - just not as sturdy as she expected from a prison. Then again, the Iranians didn't have to deal with scorpion people or minotaurs.

But inside, the prison didn't look like the Earth prisons Adora had seen in the movies and TV shows. Although those had been mostly American ones. Here, the cells were packed with people. Fortunately, in a perverted sense, a lot of the people they were here to rescue were in solitary cells, so they should be able to get them out easily enough.

She looked at the screen mounted inside the shuttle's bridge. The other shuttles were in position as well. Glimmer and Bow's was reporting ready, as were Scorpia and Perfuma's and Netossa and Spinnerella's. That left Mermista and Sea Hawk's - no, here came the green light. Adora released a small sigh of relief.

"Not even Sea Hawk would set the shuttle on fire," Catra commented behind her. "Mermista made that clear."

"And he wouldn't want people to suffer in prison," Adora said. Sea Hawk wasn't as bad as some people claimed. He just was sometimes, a lot of times, to be honest, a bit too impulsive. But they were ready, their shuttle hovering over their target - which was near a river, so Mermista would be able to use her power to the fullest.

Only one shuttle wasn't ready yet. And it was the one Adora worried the most. In theory, the team it carried should have no trouble with this mission. Between Frosta's power and Castaspella's magic, they should be able to deal with any

complications that cropped up. But pairing Frosta with Castaspella was a bit chancy. The princess got along well with Micah, but his sister… On the other hand, the only alternatives would have been Entrapta or Hordak, and everyone was aware of how either would have been a bad choice.

"And there go our problem children," Catra said as the last shuttle reported in.

"Don't call them that," Adora replied. Frosta would take offence.

Catra shrugged. She bent forward and reported to Entrapta and the others in the orbiting frigate providing overwatch and reserves. "All Shuttles are ready."

"Alright! Almost on time!" Entrapta's cheerful voice sounded through the comm. "But that's why we have enough leeway in the schedule! So, it's past midnight, the guards have changed, and the relieved ones have returned to their quarters. We're ready to deploy Blackout!"

And start the rescue. Adora took a deep breath. "Do it!"

"And here we go!"

A moment later, the lights started to go out in Tehran - entire blocks went dark in seconds. The only areas still shining brightly were the ones containing hospitals. And, unfortunately, the prison below them - the Iranians had backup generators for such an event. But this was mostly to disrupt Iranian communications, not to take out the power in the prison.

That was left to the stealthy guard bots dropping from the shuttles. They were supposed to protect hacking bots - but that meant they could wreck power generators just fine.

Half a minute later, the lights went out in the prison as well.

"Go!" Adora announced, stepping off the ramp and jumping down.

She landed on the flat roof next to a guard tower. The soldiers inside were just switching on flashlights. Before they could illuminate the area outside, though, Catra landed on top of the tower and swung over the roof, through the closest window.

Adora heard a startled sound followed by the rapid discharges of a shock stick hitting people.

Her lover could handle this, she told herself as she jumped off the roof and landed on the next one, where the Iranians had installed a heavy machine gun. Its crew was already swinging it around, cones of bright light sweeping through the darkness.

Adora jumped before they spotted her and landed directly on the gun, wrecking it with a swipe of her sword. A swing with the flat of her blade and a kick took the crew out, sending two skidding over the roof for a few yards - she had held back - and one flipping through the air to land on his back on the other side.

She quickly looked around. Catra was dismantling another guard tower. The missile launcher emplacement had the soldiers run away screaming from their own weapons - Melog was having fun with illusions.

Adora jumped again, this time down to the yard, where the Iranians had stationed an anti-aircraft gun. A guard bot had hit its power generator, though, so the soldiers were trying to move it by hand - which was going slow and distracted them enough for Adora to reach them without anyone spotting her.

She grabbed the barrel, crushing it in the process, and ripped the entire gun out from its emplacement before hurling it at its twin on the other side of the yard. A few screams sounded, followed by shooting from the rooftops.

Adora clenched her teeth and quickly glanced up.

“They’re shooting at Shadows,” Catra said, landing next to her on all fours. “The guards on the roof are out. Melog’s handling the troops outside the prison. Let’s go break in!”

“Yes.” Adora nodded at her lover and dashed forward. Her sword made short work of the door there, and a moment later, they were both inside the prison.

She heard more screaming - from inside the prison’s cell tracts.

“The prisoners have woken up,” Catra said. “Let’s hurry.”

They would be scared, not knowing what was going on, trapped in their cells.

Adora nodded again, and both were off towards the solitary cells.

A door barred their way into the general prison area, but Catra passed Adora and shredded the hinges with her claws so she could just pull it down. Then she made a gagging noise.

“What?” Adora asked.

“Just the *smell*,” Catra replied. “Come on.”

A few steps later, Adora realised what her lover meant. The smell of so many people forced into small rooms, without adequate washing facilities… She winced. It would be even worse for Catra, with her finer nose. Memories of doing laundry duty as a cadet rose in her, and she shook her head to focus. They were here to save people!

They passed the cell doors, light from her sword illuminating the dark hallway, and the mutterings and confused cries changed to surprised exclamations - and then to more screaming. It was hard to make out what the prisoners were yelling in the cacophony. Some were even rattling the bars on the windows. And the screams grew louder.

Were they begging for a rescue? Adora clenched her teeth. They couldn’t stop - they had a schedule. Even with the blackout in the city, the Iranian soldiers wouldn’t be held up for too long. And they had to get the solitary cells first. A few political prisoners were held in the general area, in those cells stuffed full of people,

but they would have to wait until last - once they opened those cells, the other prisoners would probably try to escape as well, and that could cause chaos.

The screaming grew worse as they passed door after door, and the shooting outside also grew more intense. Two prison guards stormed out of a side door, sticks in hand. Both froze when they saw Adora and Catra, and before they could react, Adora sent them flying back through the door with a swipe of the flat of her sword.

There! The entrance to the special section! But three more guards and one dog were gathered there, weapons ready. Adora bared her teeth and charged. Shots rang out, but she changed her sword into a shield and caught them on it, then smashed into the men, ramming two of them into the steel door behind them and bowling over the third. Catra's shock stick took the man out while Adora slashed with her sword, cutting the steel door into several pieces that fell to the floor - next to the dog that Catra had killed.

Inside the special section, there were fewer screams - but more guards. Soldiers, Adora corrected herself as flashlights and automatic weapons trained on them and gasping yells called - probably - for help.

Once more, her shield protected her and Catra behind her as she charged down the hallway. The men were screaming, emptying their weapons to no effect. Just before she reached them, one of them screamed something about their god.

Then a blast hit Adora, and she almost stumbled as she was pushed back a few steps, sliding to a stop braced behind her shield.

"Damn suicide bomber! Must be Revolutionary Guards!" Catra hissed behind her. She was shaking her head, her ears twitching - they would be ringing, Adora realised.

The guards themselves were beyond help. Not that Adora felt particularly like helping them right now. And they were in a rush.

“Call the transport shuttle in!” she told Catra as she pulled out her pad and checked the cell numbers they needed. “Melog, keep them from shooting at it!”

There was the first cell with a supposed witch! Adora didn’t bother looking for a key and simply ripped the cell door open. “Aisha Azar?”

The woman - she looked younger than Adora but was supposedly a year older - cowered in the corner of her cell, staring at her with wide-open eyes. In the light shining from her sword, Adora spotted a bruise peeking out from under the woman’s head cover. She was trembling as well.

Adora forced herself to smile at her. “I’m Adora - She-Ra. We’re here to rescue you.” She held out her hand. “Please. We won’t harm you.”

“Come on! We’re here to help! I’m not going to hurt you!” she heard Catra behind her, talking to someone else.

She was focusing on the woman in front of her, though. “Aisha?”

Slowly, the woman nodded, taking deep, shuddering breaths.

“We’re here to save you,” Adora repeated herself.

“Shuttle’s coming in!” Catra yelled. “I’m making a door here.”

A moment and a shriek later, the sound of falling concrete was followed by faint moonlight shining into the cell tract.

“See?” Adora smiled again. “Our shuttle is here. Come on!” Should she heal the woman to show she was here to help? Or would pointing her sword at her frighten her even more?

Still trembling, Aisha grabbed her hand, and Adora led her out of the cell, towards the opening in the wall, where Catra was all but pushing a hesitating woman in similar clothes as Aisha into the shuttle.

Two down. And far more to go, Adora thought as she looked down the hallway with the many cell doors.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter watched on the split screen as the first liberated prisoners boarded the transport shuttles hovering above the various prisons.

"We're behind schedule," the Colonel muttered.

They were, but they had planned for some slack. "Iranian responses are also behind schedule," she commented.

"Yes! The scrambling of their communication is more effective than expected!" Entrapta grinned. "They're still looking for an invasion at the coast and deserts! Well, not all of them, but many."

"They seem to have expected us to follow the American plans," Hordak said.

The Colonel grumbled something Sam didn't catch. She ignored the grumbling and watched the screens. Iranian fighters were scrambling, at last. She pointed them out to Entrapta, whose hair flew over two consoles, and radar returns appeared on the screens as shuttles decloaked over the Persian Gulf.

The fighters reacted to them, turning towards the coast to meet an air strike that was a feint. That would also draw the Iranian navy into it, but it wasn't as if they mattered for this mission. With the air force - temporarily - taken care of, that left the ground forces. And they were not as easily diverted since they didn't rely

on sensors. Hacked communication could only do so much when the troops could just take a look themselves. Sooner or later, they would realise that the prisons were the target.

But even with the delays cropping up, the Etherians should be done by the time substantial forces reached any prison - Sam was tracking the armoured forces and artillery units on her main screen. Those were the most serious threats, mainly because of collateral damage to civilians. Still, even the Iranians would hesitate to shell their own capital. Or so Sam hoped.

She checked the split screens again. Dozens of prisoners, overwhelmingly women, were already inside the various transport shuttles. And more were herded into the shuttle by the princesses. Yes, they could pull this…

Catra's voice over the comms interrupted Sam's thoughts.

"We've got a problem."

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Evin Prison, Tehran, Iran, Earth, February 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We've got a problem. The stupid prisoner doesn't want to get rescued!" Catra hissed into her communicator as she stared at the man - Kamran Soroush, according to his files arrested as an enemy of the Iranian regime two years ago. "We're here to rescue you!" she repeated herself. She almost flashed her fangs at the man in wide a smile, but she remembered the reaction another prisoner had had earlier. Her ears still hurt from the shrieks of that woman.

The man shook his head. He stood with his back against the wall, but he wasn't cowering. And his eyes weren't darting around. But he was clearly afraid all the same. Just not as much as others. "No!" he repeated himself.

Perhaps he didn't understand her? She checked her flashcard for the wording in case she had made a mistake - she hadn't! - and told him again, in Persian, that they were here to rescue him.

"I am not going!" he said. He was clenching his teeth - she could see his jaw muscles working.

Catra muttered a curse under her breath. "You want to stay here?" she snapped. "Where you will get tortured?" They didn't have the time for this! The ground troops wouldn't be delayed forever, and evacuating trained troops under fire was difficult enough. Scared civilians? That would be a nightmare.

He swallowed, his lips moving for a second without a sound. Then he straightened, wincing as he squared his shoulder, and shook his head again. "I will not work with witches! Begone, jinn!"

What? She stared at him. "But… You're an enemy of the regime!" He was a political prisoner! She could see the marks torture had left on him!

In response, he closed his eyes and started mumbling - no, praying, she realised. "Fine!" she spat. "Be like that!"

She turned and left the cell, activating her communicator. "Soroush doesn't want to be saved by witches!"

"What?" Entrapta's voice told her her friend was as surprised by this as Catra herself. *"Why? That makes no sense!"*

"I don't know!" she replied. Should she just club the idiot over the head and throw him into the shuttle so they could sort this out later? Like you did with troops suffering battle shock?

"Adora!" she called out. "We've got a problem!" Where was her lover?

"Yes!" Adora replied.

There! Catra could see her head poking out of a cell.

“She doesn’t want to leave!” Adora added.

Another one? Catra blinked. “Have they gone crazy?”

“I don’t know. I…”

Something - a metal cup - bounced off the back of Adora’s head, followed by cursing in Persian. At least it sounded like cursing.

Adora turned around, and the cursing changed to praying.

“Grab her and sort it out later?” Catra suggested, eyeing the cell behind her in case the moron there got any ideas.

“That would be kidnapping!” Adora objected.

“Did you check if they are doubles?” Entrapta asked over the communicator.

How? “No, we didn’t!” Catra replied.

“The other strike teams are reporting target people refusing to come with them as well,” Hordak cut in. *“Should we authorise the use of force?”*

Great. Catra clenched her teeth and looked at Adora. That was her call.

Adora stepped out of the cell, her lips pressed together. She turned to look back inside, then shook her head slowly. “No. No, we can’t just force them to come with us,” she said, grimacing. “Not against their will.”

We could, Catra thought. And if it was a friend of hers, she would. But if those people would rather be tortured than be saved by witches… “Let’s go get the rest, then!” she snapped. Before they went crazy as well.

She ripped the next cell door off its hinges. “We’re here to rescue you!” she snapped. And before she could help herself, she added:

"Unless you refuse to be rescued by witches!"

The man inside chuckled as he shook his head. "I'm not a fool who believes those lies."

Catra grinned as she pointed him to the amp of the waiting shuttle. His eyes widened as he saw the clone standing guard there, but he quickly rallied and rushed towards the ramp, followed by a woman Adora had just rescued as well.

That left… "The ones in the general area," Catra said.

Adora nodded. "Let's go!"

But before they reached the door back to that area, the yelling and screaming from the general area changed. "Stop!" Catra hissed.

"What?" Adora slid to a stop, staring back at her.

Catra's ears twitched. As did her tail. "I can hear footsteps. Lots of them. Coming closer."

Adora blinked. But… "Did troops reach the prison?" she asked over the communicator.

Still fighting illusions.

"Melog says they're still fighting illusions," Catra told Adora. But some of the shots were much closer. Inside the prison.

"The column on the way hasn't reached the prison yet," Entrapta reported over the comms.

"We can neutralise the vehicles and troops with orbital fire support," Hordak added. *"With minimal collateral damage."*

Which was still a lot in a densely-built city in the middle of a blackout.

"No!" Adora snapped. "We need to…"

A man appeared in the doorframe leading to the general area. Not a soldier - but he was armed. And bleeding from a wound on his head. He saw them and raised his rifle.

Catra moved to the side, ducking into an empty cell, and Adora changed her sword into a shield. The shots ricochetted around the hallway. More screams from the occupied cells followed.

Adora charged the man with a grunt, smashing into him. Another appeared, wielding a stick. And behind him, more were coming. "What's happening?" she asked.

Catra cursed. "They must have released the prisoners." All the prisoners.

"But why are they attacking us?" Adora grunted as the first row broke against her shield.

"They might not recognise us and just try to escape." Catra looked around. Or they did recognise them and were promised a pardon if they beat them.

Or they just want to kill witches, she silently added as she looked through the hole in the wall at the city. She could see some lights from vehicles, from what looked like a fire, and tracers from blindly firing guns in the sky.

"We need to leave," she said.

"But…" Adora grunted as she heaved and sent the mob's next row stumbling back. "There are still prisoners to save!"

"We can't find them in the mob." If they were still alive. "Come on, Adora!" Catra jumped on the ramp leading into the hovering shuttle. "The soldiers will be here soon. Melog!"

Here they came, darting around the corner, then jumping up, pushing off the wall and landing on the ramp. Inside, the dozens of people they had rescued cowered, staring at Catra's friend.

Catra ignored them for now and turned back. "Adora!"

After a moment, the idiot finally whirled around and sprinted towards the ramp. Howling, the mob gave chase.

Adora leapt on the ramp, and Catra grabbed her arm and pulled her inside. "Close the ramp and get us out!" she yelled at the pilot. "And engage the stealth system!" There was no longer any need to keep the ramp visible.

The mob reached the hole in the wall right when the shuttle started accelerating and fading out of view. Catra saw several of the men getting pushed through the hole by the mass of people behind them, falling down on the jagged chunks of concrete below.

"I don't think we'll have plausible deniability," she muttered.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...unconfirmed reports of blackouts and shooting in Tehran and other Iranian cities. The Iranian government has declared a state of emergency and…"

"...rumours of air strikes targeting several cities in Iran abound, though no information…"

"...air raid alerts have been raised according to the Swiss embassy in Tehran…"

"...the United Nations Security Council is assembling for an emergency session following a supposed attack on Iran by…"

Jack O'Neill tried to ignore the rapidly switching TV channels blathering in the background. The news wouldn't have any useful information at his point. It was much too soon - and Iran wasn't a

country where the press could get the truth, anyway. It was all rumours and hysteria.

He focused on the feeds from the spybots deployed by the Etherians, the images from orbital observation and the results from Carter's magic scanner. And those didn't paint a pretty picture.

"That's a massacre happening down there," he muttered. A column of ground forces had reached the Evin prison in Tehran and started to fight the prisoners. With predictable results - the Revolutionary Guards weren't as good as the Iranian propaganda claimed, but you didn't need elite troops to massacre prisoners armed with a few guns and sticks.

"But why are they doing this?" Entrapta asked. "We've already left the prison!" Her hair tendrils flew over the consoles, and more feeds opened up, prompting a gasp from her at some particularly gruesome scenes.

"They probably have orders to stop a prison break at any cost - this prison is where they keep most of their political prisoners." Kept, Jack reminded himself - the Etherians had gotten most of them out. And the ones who had chosen to stay behind… He pressed his lips together as he glanced at the scanner's feed. The mob of other prisoners hadn't spared anyone left behind, and they hadn't died quickly or easily.

But the Iranian soldiers were not taking any chances. Or didn't want any witnesses left. Or someone had started shooting, someone had shot back, and things had gone out of control. Jack knew from experience how quickly shit like that could happen.

"But the Iranians released the prisoners in the first place!" Entrapta protested.

"That doesn't mean the soldiers know that," Jack said. Or that they would care.

“A number of prisoners have managed to escape the prison’s boundaries,” Carter pointed out. “But most of them have been pushed back into the prison.”

Or killed. Jack nodded. The blackout would make it easy to hide from the soldiers once you got away from the prison. But come morning, there would be man hunts. The Iranian regime would want to see every witch and dissident captured or killed, and they wouldn’t know who might have escaped on foot and who went with the Etherians. And that the Etherians had done this was clear.

He glanced at the screen showing a prison covered with walls of ice. And one covered with plants. And one buried under nets. And one with a new moat around it. And a lake inside it. As soon as they had realised that the jig was up, the Etherians had dropped any attempt at being subtle. Despite Hordak asking, several times, they hadn’t used orbital fire support, but that was a small consolation with tanks literally sent flying by magical hurricanes. Or being thrown around like toys. Or swept away by a mini-tsunami.

“Aquaman better shape up,” he mumbled.

“Sir?”

“Nothing,” he quickly said. “So, the Iranians won’t have any trouble proving who did this.”

“No, sir.”

Jack sighed. “And they’ll blame all the dead on the Etherians.” That was how those regimes operated.

“They can’t!” Entrapta protested. “We have them on record! We didn’t kill those people!”

“They’ll do it anyway,” Jack told her. “And their allies will pretend to believe them and claim our records are fakes.”

“But…” Entrapta closed her mouth. “Politics again.”

“Yes.”

“There will be repercussions.” Daniel had stopped staring at the feeds from the massacre. “But I think it’s too early to tell what they will be.”

“Well, one thing is sure,” Jack said, snorting. “The United Nations won’t do anything.” Whatever the Security Council would decide, someone would veto it.

“Is that good?” Entrapta cocked her head.

“It’s business as usual,” Jack said, shrugging.

“Iran and their allies - and any countries with similar regimes or policies - will try to use this to attack the Alliance,” Daniel said. “The question is how Russia and China will react.”

And no one could predict what they would do. Not in this crazy new world. “Just keep your scanners peeled on the entire country,” Jack said. “I wouldn’t put it past the Iranian regime to kill their own civilians and try to frame you for it.”

“They’re already killing their own civilians,” Daniel pointed out. “In fact, they have done so for a long time and wanted to kill more people - it’s what started this, actually.”

“Yes, yes.” Jack scoffed. “I’m talking about blowing up apartment buildings and claiming they were targeted by us.”

“It would be hard for them to fake the effects of our cannons,” Hordak commented. “Any such claim wouldn’t be believable.”

“Oh, many would believe it anyway. Or claim to believe it,” Jack told him. “They won’t let little things like facts and proof get in the way of a useful lie.”

“Then they are fools,” Hordak said with a scoff.

“Mh.” Jack wasn’t so sure about that.

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Earth Orbit, Solar System, February 21st, 1999 (Earth Time)

Adora watched as, once more, the holographic projection showed a mob of men rushing through the hallways of Evin Prison. Some of them stopped at an open cell door. One of the men looked inside, at the man standing there, then turned to the others, saying something and raising his fist.

A moment later, people stormed the cell, dragging the flailing man out. Others cheered - and lashed out at him. By the time they reached the hole in the wall Adora had left, the man couldn’t walk any more and was being carried. And thrown through the hole. She winced at the way the man’s body crashed on top of the sharp concrete chunks below. Then the mob outside rushed in, kicking and hitting him until…

“Stop watching this,” she heard Catra say behind her. “He wanted to stay behind. They tortured him, and he still decided to stay in his cell. As did the others. Can’t save people from being stupid.”

“I should have dragged them with us against their will,” Adora retorted. They would still be alive if she had done that.

Catra shrugged. “They chose this. It’s their own fault.”

“They didn’t expect to be killed.” And to be killed like this - beaten to death by a mob. Or something worse, in some cases…

“They should have.” Catra shrugged again, though it felt a bit forced to Adora. “They lived there. Soroush had been in prison for two years already. The other idiots weren’t new to this either.”

“And they chose this.” Glimmer had arrived on the bridge, followed by Bow. “We have to respect that, even if it’s stupid.

Even when it's suicidally stupid. As long as they only hurt themselves, we have to respect that."

"What about their families?" Adora snapped. To lose a loved one, especially like this, would hurt. Horribly.

Glimmer frowned. "That's on them as well. They could have gone with us."

"Unless they feared that that would endanger their families." Daniel had arrived as well.

"They would go after the families of prisoners?" Adora gasped. If Soroush, if the others, had chosen to die in order to spare their families… She felt her stomach twist at the thought.

"We would have stopped the Iranians if they wanted to do that," Glimmer spat. "We won't let anyone use hostages like that."

"But would they know this?" Daniel asked. "The prisoners - and the Iranian government, I guess."

"Well, they know they can't stop us," Catra said, pointing at the big screen on the bridge, where a view of Tehran from their air was being shown. She pushed a button, and a man's voice filled the bridge.

"...and while the fires have been extinguished, the damage remains. Power has yet to be restored to large parts of the city, and despite the heavy police and military presence on the streets, there have been reports of looting while people gather for protests against the attack on the city. The Iranian government has condemned the attack as an unprovoked crime against humanity, calling for support from the United Nations against this violation of their national sovereignty."

"That was a raid, not an attack," Catra said.

"I don't think they care about the difference," Daniel told her.

“Their military does,” Catra retorted. “They know they can’t stop us - or keep us from repeating this if we want to. Do you think they’ll risk another intervention?”

Daniel winced. “They might not think there’s an acceptable alternative. If those protests turn against the government…”

Adora closed her eyes for a moment. This was… It was crazy! “Would they really risk more attacks just to… stay in power?”

“Yes,” Daniel said, nodding firmly. “I mean, they might honestly believe they have no choice, or that they have no alternative because you’ll, ah, come back to wipe them out, but many such regimes have shown that they would rather see their country be destroyed than lose power. In the case of Iran, that’s complicated by the religious aspect. Significant parts of the government and of the population may honestly believe that their faith compels them to continue with their, ah, chosen course of action.”

“You mean, murder all so-called witches,” Glimmer flatly stated.

“Yes.”

“If they want to commit genocide, we’ll stop them,” Glimmer said with a grim expression.

Adora nodded, pressing her lips together. Some lines wouldn’t be crossed. Not if she could do something about it. And she could. “Yes. But we need to find a way to stop them without hurting innocents.”

She looked at the others. Sam and Entrapta - and Hordak - were in their spacelab, Jack and Teal’c had gone back to Stargate Command with the princesses who would return to Etheria, but Glimmer, Bow, Catra and Daniel nodded.

Though they didn’t look any more confident that they would manage that than Adora felt herself. And that wasn’t a good sign, not with the United Nations emergency session coming up. And the Alliance meeting.

Still… some things had to be stopped no matter how much it cost you.

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Spacelab, Earth Orbit, February 21st, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and so the Hacking and Guard Bots performed according to our projections. They accomplished their missions in support of the main mission. With their limited armament, even striking from ambush would have been unlikely to be effective for directly dealing with the organised military response if the Iranian government to our incursion, but they proved sufficiently effective in electronic warfare and for temporarily disabling key Iranian infrastructure. I would suggest developing a variant as a platform to deliver more lethal ordnance - it should be quite effective for surprise attacks against enemy positions, although we would likely have to improve the stealth system when facing more advanced sensors such as those the Goa'uld use."

Samantha Carter nodded as Hordak finished his take on the mission's debriefing. Unsurprisingly, he had, rather coldly, focused on the military aspects of the entire affair. And, equally unsurprisingly, he was thinking of developing more effective weapons.

"Oh! Do you mean Bomber Bots? Stealth Bomber Bots? I think that should be possible! Between the Spy Bots in space and the Guard Bots, I think we have the base for a fitting control matrix. Although we will have to finetune it, of course, once we have finalised the bot's capabilities."

And, also unsurprisingly, Entrapta enthusiastically reacted to the engineering challenges such a stealth bot would pose. Of course, Sam had a few thoughts about such a project herself, based on what she knew about the Stealth Bombers of the Air Force, and now that the mission was over, she didn't have to restrict her involvement to mere observation any more. Hordak was correct in his opinion that a stealth bomber bot would be very useful for the

war against the Goa'uld. It would certainly save lives when bots could replace recon and special forces. At least for a time. "And we will have to continue improving the stealth system," she pointed out. "To keep up with whatever the Goa'uld develop once they are aware of the bots."

"Of course," Hordak said. His habitual frown didn't change much, but his tone clearly indicated that he thought this obvious.

"We need to ensure that other scientists can take over that, then," Sam told him. "Since we might have to deal with other projects." The number of projects she had to put on the back burner just to deal with the most current crisis was far too high already, and she didn't expect that to change.

"Are scientists of sufficient skill and experience to take over the continuing development of such bots available?" Hordak asked.

"And can we trust them to treat the bots right?" Entrapta added. "It's a moral question as well."

"Currently?" Sam shook her head. "No." The stealth system used some of their most advanced technology. Most of the top scientists in the aerospace field were working with conventional shuttles - well, conventional for advanced technology. "Even with personal instruction, It will take some time for any scientists we might choose to reach the level of competency necessary to contribute to our work here, much less take over developing such bots." And they would have to be vetted and read in first.

"OK!" Entrapta was undaunted. "So, we should start looking for a good scientist! We could ask Bow, I guess, but he has his own projects."

And missions to run. Bow was very skilled, but - like Sam - he would be needed for a variety of tasks.

"And we need to prepare a guide so people can catch up without us having to teach them!" Entrapta went on.

Hordak nodded. “Yes. Teaching the basics to others wouldn’t be a very efficient use of our time. We cannot afford to neglect our other duties.”

Sam narrowed her eyes. This made sense and mirrored her own thoughts, but… There was something else as well that Hordak wasn’t saying out loud.

“Could we construct a teacher bot? Not like our bots, more like Alpha.” Entrapta wrinkled her nose.

A bot like Alpha? That would certainly be a great help for many tasks, including instructing new scientists. On the other hand, more artificial intelligences like Alpha might also cause trouble. Especially if they shared some of Alpha’s attitude and views.

But they couldn’t use the sapient bots like Emily for this - they had adapted for combat, not for teaching, and even sapient, they were still quite limited and alien in some of their views.

“We probably should look into this,” Sam said. They needed to regularly check with Alpha anyway, to ensure Loki was behaving.

“Yes!”

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Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, February 22nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“...and my country calls upon all peaceful, civilised countries to condemn this unprovoked aggression. Hundreds of people - civilians - were killed during this attack. Its transgressors and their allies have blood on their hands, and…”

Catra rolled her eyes as the Iranian ambassador to the United Nations droned on. “Couldn’t even send their minister?” she mumbled. “Does anyone believe their lies?

“Shh!” Adora hissed. Her lover, of course, was sitting straight in her seat, paying attention as if this was an important briefing instead of some rehearsed performance.

“We already know what they’re going to say - they’ve been spreading it all over the news,” Catra retorted. And the media had jumped on it like some famished animals on a scrap of food. Catra still disagreed with Glimmer’s insistence that they waited for the United Nations emergency session to release their own data. A concerted effort to flood the media with the material that they had on record would have been better. It would also have let them do something before today - waiting and watching the smear campaign had been extremely annoying.

“...and we demand that the creatures and people responsible be held accountable! We demand their extraction so they can be tried in Iran and that reparations be paid for the massive damage my country suffered.” With a nod and a glare, the ambassador sat down.

Catra frowned as the ambassador of Saudi Arabia stood to speak next. “They’re calling us creatures now?” she whispered. The Iranians really weren’t bothering to hide their views.

But neither were the Saudi Arabians, it seemed - their ambassador’s speech was almost a copy of the Iranians, with a few ‘past disagreements notwithstanding’ and ‘fundamental principles of international law’ being thrown in. If even a traditional enemy of Iran was supporting them, this didn’t look good. Of course, they had expected that since both countries had the same policies regarding magic.

Catra checked the list. Half a dozen more countries from the ‘Middle East’ were on it. She sighed. This would be a long day. At least the Security Council meeting had been short once it became clear that any decision would be vetoed.

*****

"...but there is one more part to discuss. This wasn't merely an intervention by an alien power. The Etherians who violated the sovereignity of Iran were supported by NATO forces."

Catra narrowed her eyes. This was new. The Chinese ambassador, so far, had been going on about national sovereignty and internal affairs but had not as much supported Iran's position as he had criticised the intervention. And now he was attacking their allies?

"While the Alliance was described as aimed at an alien Empire bent on conquering Earth, and the Alliance leadership had released a statement that they did not seek to meddle in International politics, Alliance forces provided intelligence and active support for the attack. China is concerned about this duplicity. It looks like the West is using the opportunity to, once more, engage in colonialist interventions in other countries to impose their values on others. This cannot be tolerated!"

Catra's ears were hard-pressed to pick up individual sentences from the murmuring this caused, but the way many ambassadors were nodding at those words showed what they thought about this well enough.

Glimmer stood up. And she looked as angry, or even more, as Catra felt. "This is an outrage!" she began. "I cannot believe the lies spread by members of this assembly. First, we - the Princess Alliance - clearly stated that we wouldn't intervene in Earth politics as long as it didn't involve genocide and other grave human rights violations. Rights the United Nations themselves have enshrined. That national sovereignty provides no excuse for such crimes against humanity has been an accepted principle on your planet for decades!"

"My country has not committed any such crimes!" the Iranian ambassador interjected.

Glimmer sneered. "You declared magic a capital crime. That's a clear intent to commit genocide against everyone with the talent for magic - something you are born with."

More protests were raised, drowning out her next words until the Secretary-General managed to calm things down.

"I don't care about your excuses," Glimmer went on. "You persecute people for something they were born with and can't help. Of course, we would intervene."

"Interventions have to be mandated by resolutions of the United Nations. Without such a resolution, any intervention is illegal," the Russian ambassador replied.

"That's your opinion," Glimmer retorted. "We don't share it. And we have the data to prove our claims - and to disprove the accusations levelled against us and our allies. None of them provided any support for this, by the way. They merely observed." She pushed a button, and the big projection behind her was filled with a picture of the Evin Prison taken with their most advanced scanner, quickly zooming in. "We have documented the entire mission and the abuses committed by the Iranian authorities in prison," she went on as the picture changed to a video showing the beating of a woman in a cell. "We also have detailed recordings to prove that we didn't fire on any civilians and that the deaths that were suffered during the intervention are the fault of the Iranian authorities and individual Iranians." More pictures and videos appeared. A lot of them were rather brutal.

The assembly erupted in whispering, muttering and outright gasping and yelling. But, Catra realised with twitching ears, the outrage - of those ambassadors from countries not in the Alliance or associated with them - wasn't directed at the actions of the Iranians. It was directed at the 'spying' and 'surveillance' by the Etherians.

It seemed most Earth governments hadn't understood just how good their sensors were, and how much they could detect, until now.

She glanced at the Secretary-General. The man was smiling.

*****

Faith

Earth Orbit, February 23rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"The Secretary-General wants your magic scanner for the United Nations?" Jack O'Neill was sure he must have misunderstood Glimmer. This was absurd. Carter and Entrapta's scanner was a major military... well, not a military secret; too many knew about it, but it was a major military asset. The Goa'uld had no counter to it, so far, and its utility was almost limitless.

"Yes. Well, to be precise, he wants it to be used by a special task force of the United Nations Commission on Human Rights," Glimmer explained. "To investigate claims of human rights violations."

Oh. Jack blinked. That was… still insane. Handing over such an asset to the United Nations? To the United Nations Commission on Human Rights? Some of its members were amongst the worst offenders, if Jack remembered correctly - he hadn't exactly kept up with a toothless UN commission. "Really?" he said, raising his eyebrows.

"Well, it makes sense," Daniel said. "The recordings of torture and abuse in Iran you published showed everyone what your scanners could do. Of course, the United Nations would want to use that to document other human rights violations."

Jack scoffed. "And what for? Not even with the proof you presented, the United Nations were willing to condemn Iran."

"Well, they've decided to investigate the whole thing," Adora said. "And we've disproven the Iranian lies."

If truth counted for anything in politics… Jack shook his head. "I doubt anything will come off it. Too many countries have too much to lose if they don't back Iran." Even in the USA, some

pundits had acted as if the Etherians using the scanner on Iranian prisons was worse than torturing and murdering prisoners.

"But why?" Adora asked. "We've proved that Iran is lying about everything. Does that mean everyone supporting them is as bad as they are?"

"No," Glimmer replied. "A number have similar or the same policies against magic, but few are as blatantly murderous. But a lot of countries claim that their sovereignty is more important than human rights."

"No country's perfect," Jack said. "Every country has something that they aren't proud of." Even America. Especially America, as he knew quite well.

"We know that." Glimmer rolled her eyes. "But not every country wants to murder people for being born with magic. They know we won't intervene for individual crimes - we haven't intervened even after lynchings."

"They might not believe that," Daniel pointed out. "Or they fear you'll escalate after having dealt with the worst offenders. It's happened before." He pushed his glasses up his nose. "But back to the United Nations' request. Are you going to grant it?"

Of course not! Jack rolled his eyes.

"We don't trust them enough to hand over such advanced technology," Glimmer replied. "Of course, they can't steal it - we'd easily find it with our scanner - but the potential for abuse is too great."

Jack nodded.

"And if we keep the scanner but operate it on request, they can claim that we manipulated the results," Bow added. "Even if we let them supervise."

That was one obvious angle for Iran and its supporters: Claim the Etherian data was fake. It wasn't very convincing, of course - not with the first interviews of some of the dissidents and witches the Etherians had broken out of prison hitting the news - but in politics, usually, all you needed was a plausible-sounding excuse.

"But that's no reason not to provide help," Adora retorted. "Even if only our friends believe us, we still should document and prove human rights violations."

"And then just let them continue doing it?" Catra scoffed. "What good is documenting a crime if you don't stop it?"

"Do you want to risk another massacre? Or more countries opposing the Alliance?" Glimmer shook her head.

"What can they do?" Daniel asked. "Iran couldn't stop you. I doubt even China or Russia could stop you."

"If you ignore their nukes," Jack pointed out. He expected both countries to revise their stated conditions under which they would consider using nuclear weapons. Probably to include an alien invasion on their soil.

"We're aware of that threat," Adora said. "We're monitoring those bombs."

Jack wasn't sure if he should feel relieved or concerned about that comment. Or if he should ask if that meant what he thought it meant - that the Etherian ships in orbit would stop any nuclear launches.

"And they can't stop us, but they can make the cost of an intervention too high to attempt it short of the worst cases," Glimmer went on. "We don't have the capability to take over a country, much less several. Certainly not if they start a guerilla war. Not us, not the Alliance."

"But a prison break isn't an invasion," Daniel protested. "You wouldn't stay and take over."

"And how long would a ruler last if we keep breaking out their prisoners and crushing their military?" Glimmer asked. "Your rulers don't even have magic powers to legitimise your rule, and even a princess's rule would be threatened if her country kept being invaded and her troops defeated."

"And a regime change is never a nice, smooth affair," Jack cut in before Daniel could ask. "The more brutal a regime was, the more bad blood built up and the more accounts will be settled once it ends. So, unless you want more massacres, you need to be ready to intervene and occupy a country before its regime falls."

His friend frowned. "You mean… the Iranian regime, and other regimes like them, could hold themselves hostage to force us not to topple them? That sounds absurd."

It did sound like that scene from Blazing Saddles.

"They're holding their people hostage," Glimmer pointed out. "Because the people are the ones who will be suffering."

"Right."

"They're suffering anyway," Catra said.

"But if a country plunges into anarchy, it's going to get much, much worse. Just look at Somalia," Jack said.

"We've read about that," Adora said.

"And we're aware that even some of the victims of the current rulers would fight us if we stayed in their country," Glimmer said, scowling.

Jack nodded. Between religious fanatism and plain old 'my country, right or wrong' patriotism, any occupation of Iran or its neighbouring countries would be a terrible mess.

"But we still can help the United Nations," Adora said. "At least, with proof of human rights violations, the guilty countries will

have more trouble covering it up. And everyone will know what they did."

"And the Alliance can sanction them," Daniel added with an optimistic smile.

Jack suppressed a scoff. Sanctions didn't really work well, in his opinion. They took too long even if they worked. And the introduction of advanced technology was already causing upheavals in the economy. On the other hand, that might mean some of the sanctions might be more effective - especially for countries that didn't have access to alien technology and a war economy to compensate for the results.

Things might get a bit more interesting.

*****

"...but even with the fires under control and power slowly being restored, the situation in Tehran remains far from normal. Most Western embassies still present in the country have evacuated their staff in response to increasingly furious protests by Iranians blaming the entire West for the Etherian intervention. The efforts of the authorities to protect the embassies have been deemed lacklustre by some sources, prompting fears of a second Iranian Hostage Crisis. Although after the Etherians' demonstration of their power, it is very doubtful that an attempt to take civilians hostage would result in anything but a swifter and harsher response with overwhelming force since Queen Glimmer left no doubt that the Etherians wouldn't tolerate atrocities against civilians."

"At least as long as they aren't the ones committing them, Bob. We all saw the reports about civilian casualties in Tehran."

"Those reports haven't been substantiated by any proof, though, Jim. And the data the Etherians have presented to the United Nations has been said to convincingly refute the Iranian claims."

"Yes, but neither claim has been independently verified, right? It's basically one word against another, and who knows who you can trust? Your government?"

Adora frowned as both men on the screen laughed at their own joke. "Our data proves our innocence," she muttered.

"Well, this channel isn't the most reputable," Daniel said. "The other channels are less, ah…"

"...lying?" Adora asked.

"It's not lying, technically. They merely… report in a slightly biased way." Daniel smiled weakly. "Though I would have expected this particular channel to be a bit more, ah, supportive of our government's policies about Iran. They have been very vocal in their criticism of the Iranian regime in the past."

That was weird. Or not. "Just because they don't like Iran doesn't mean they like us," Adora told him. She thought she remembered that news channel as being quite hostile towards them after they had revealed themselves to Earth - after First Contact, as the humans called it, even though the actual First Contact had happened on Etheria.

"Or they just focus on what gets better ratings - and that's controversial news bites, not facts and truth," Jack cut in. "That's how the news works, Daniel."

"That's a very cynical view, Jack. And incorrect. There are trustworthy news sources."

"But that channel's not one of them." Jack grinned.

But people are still watching it, Adora thought. And why would they be watching a news channel if they didn't trust it? She shook her head. "Darla, change the channel, please."

The picture of the two men vanished in the middle of a tasteless joke about the 'manhunt' for escaped prisoners in Tehran,

replaced by footage from the United Nations building in Geneva.

"...that the recent proposal of the Secretary-General of the United Nations has caused a deep rift in the organisation. And while much of the outrage stems from countries with very questionable reputations concerning human rights, many diplomats from Western countries have, publicly and privately, voiced concerns about the increasing influence of the Etherians on world politics, and that the United Nations should not be allowed to become dependent on their power even if it was used to protect human rights."

"But they asked us!" Adora hissed. "That wasn't our idea!"

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Spacelab, Earth Orbit, February 23rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and so we've decided to grant the request by the Secretary-General, but with restrictions. A delegation of their committee can ask for support, and we will use a scanner to provide the information they seek while they supervise to ensure the data won't be tampered with. They won't be allowed to use the scanner themselves. So… could you build a spare magic scanner and instruct the clones on how to use it?"

Glimmer's request surprised Samantha Carter. She hadn't expected that. Not after the United Nations General Assembly session had ended in a memorable row over the scanner data taken from Iran's prisons.

Entrapta, though, nodded. "Sure thing, Glimmer! We'll build a spare one - well, we can take one of our spares. Do you want it to be able to tap into our scanner network? It would make information gathering easier and faster if it had access to all the data from the fleet in orbit. It would allow the operators to narrow down the areas of interest as well."

"Wouldn't that reveal the capabilities of our sensors?" Hordak cut in.

On the big screen in the spacelab, Glimmer shook her head. *"They already know what the magic scanner can do. Revealing that we have a sensor network when most Earth nations use similar setups isn't anything to worry about."*

"What about our stealth bots?" Hordak asked.

"They already know we have stealth shuttles since we used them in the mission. And they assume we have magic ways to turn invisible."

Hordak nodded, apparently satisfied.

"Alright. See you later. Don't work overnight again!" Glimmer's picture vanished.

"So! We'll have to update the spare scanner we stored in the lab, I think. Probably add some safety features, right?" Entrapta asked.

"Yes," Sam said. "And a tracking device." They could track it with a scanner, but a beacon would make it easier and quicker. Maybe a self-destruct device… no, that would probably be too much. Besides, she doubted that any country would risk retaliation by the fleet and steal the scanner. Although if they planned to frame someone else… She shook her head. "I'm still surprised that the secretary-general asked for this."

"Why? If they want to gather data about human rights violations, the scanner is perfect. Well, for some cases, we would need spy bots as well, I think, but overall, it's what they need," Entrapta said.

"Most people don't like the thought that we could be watching everything they are doing." Sam felt a bit queasy about that herself - and she could be sure the scanner wouldn't be used on her.

"Understandable," Hordak said. After a moment - he must have noticed Entrapta's surprise, though Sam hadn't expected this

either - he added: “Horde Prime knows all. Horde Prime sees all.”

Ah. Sam nodded. Of course.

“Oh.” Entrpata bit her lower lip. “But we aren’t Horde Prime. And we won’t abuse it!”

“The people on Earth don’t know that,” Sam pointed out.

“Most likely because they would abuse it,” Hordak said.

Sam frowned, but she couldn’t claim he was wrong. Even parts of the United States government might be tempted to abuse such a scanner - history proved that.

“You mean like Horde Prime?” Entrapta asked. She looked… not shocked, but ill at ease, Sam found.

“The similarities between Horde Prime’s… habits and many ideologies on Earth are striking,” Hordak said.

“We’ve made progress, but many countries are still ruled by autocracies,” Sam agreed. “Although many of the worst examples are gone.” Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union had been vanquished. China… was slowly reforming, according to her knowledge. But the massacre on Tiananmen Square happened less than ten years ago.

“I was mostly thinking of your most popular religions,” Hordak said. “The way they indoctrinate their followers is very much like Horde Prime acted.”

“What?” Sam snapped before she could help herself.

“Many humans believe in an all-mighty god whose commands they have to obey. A god who sees all and knows all they do. They are raised in that belief and taught not to question their god’s commands. Like Horde Prime raised us,” Hordak explained.

“That’s… not correct,” Sam said. “At least not for the mainstream religions. Some sects might act like that, but they are the exception.”

“Really?” Hordak tilted his head. “How do you explain the common belief in such a god then, when no facts support their existence?”

“That’s because it’s a matter of faith,” Sam said. For a moment, she felt like she was back in college, watching a debate between a few vocal students. “You can’t prove or disprove the existence of God.”

“Assuming something exists without any data supporting that doesn’t seem very scientific,” Entrapta pointed out.

“It’s not a scientific matter,” Sam retorted. “It’s a personal matter for most.”

“Quite public for a personal matter,” Hordak said. “It’s also striking how similar the most popular religions, at least those which postulate that there is only one god, are, yet how much their respective followers seem to focus on insignificant differences to condemn each other.”

“That’s based on history - the monotheistic religions share a common origin,” Sam said.

“I didn’t know you studied Earth religions,” Entrapta said - to Hordak.

“I felt it would be prudent to look into the matter, with Priest starting the Church of She-Ra,” Hordak said.

“Do you think he’s going use Earth religions as examples to follow?” Entrapta asked.

“He has people proselytising like certain Christian Churches,” Sam pointed out.

“That’s a rather insignificant similarity.” Hordak shook his head. “But even if he wanted to follow the examples provided by Earth religions, he couldn’t. Adora is real - and vocal. He cannot speak in her name without her correcting him, should she need to.”

“And yet, she hasn’t been able to convince him that she isn’t a goddess,” Sam said.

“Yes.” Hordak nodded. “Though that might be because she cannot disprove that she is a goddess. She has all the powers that most Earth gods are supposed to have. And she has used them, in front of witnesses, and in scientifically provable ways.”

“And yet she isn’t a goddess,” Sam said. “She said so.”

“Earth religions have numerous examples of gods or their messengers hiding their nature,” Hordak retorted. “Usually to test their followers.”

“Adora wouldn’t do that, though,” Entrapta pointed out. “She wouldn’t play with people’s lives like that.”

“She wouldn’t,” Hordak agreed. “But like many followers of a religion I’ve read about, Priest won’t be deterred by that. It’s a very minor inconsistency compared to the fallacies in the dogmas of most Earth religions. In fact, Adora’s insistence that she is no goddess and that she doesn’t want to be worshipped might be the most important reason that Priest and his followers keep worshipping her. She is very much the antithesis of Horde Prime. She doesn’t demand uncritical obedience or blind faith. She wants to help and protect people, not oppress and conquer them. Or vanquish them. And she leads by example. She does what she can to help others, not herself.”

“Oh.” Entrapta nodded. “That makes a lot of sense. And her powers might support that - we still don’t know how She-Ra’s power is granted to someone, but the data we have, the histories of past She-Ra’s, show that there must be some process of

selection when a new She-Ra acquired her powers. All of them were protectors of Etheria, not conquerors."

According to the history books, Sam thought. Those could be manipulated.

"Some think that Etheria, or Etheria's magic, chooses She-Ra, but whether that means the planet or its magic is sentient or even sapient is unclear," Entrapta went on. "Imagine if we could find out if that's the case! Would that qualify as proving a god exists?"

"I don't think there's a scientific definition of godhood," Sam said.

Her friend frowned. "There should be one. How can we call the Goa'uld false gods if we don't have a definition for what a real god is?"

"Yes," Hordak said. "That seems a bit hypocritical."

"What is considered a god is a matter of faith, not science," Sam said. "But I think we should focus on our projects - we have a lot to do."

"Yes! Let's do science!" Entrapta cheered.

Sam smiled, relieved. She really didn't want to continue this discussion. She was a scientist, not a theologian.

Though she suspected that a theologian wouldn't have any better answers, either. Especially about the parallels to Horde Prime's rule. Or how to define what was a real god.

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P.O.W. Camp "Hotchins", Newfoundland, Canada, February 24th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and tensions remain high as several countries have protested vehemently against the Secretary-General's request to the Etherians for support for fact-finding missions of the United

Nations Commission on Human Rights. A proposal in the Security Council to prohibit such measures was vetoed, prompting Russia and China to voice concerns about the influence Etheria has on its allies on Earth. We have here in the studio Professor Keith Harcrouft of Yale. Hello, Professor. Thank you for coming."

"Thank you for inviting me."

"Well, you're one of the most famous experts on the constitution. And, speaking of the constitution, can you tell us what it says about the kind of spying the Etherians apparently do?"

The professor on the screen cleared his throat. *"Well, to answer that question, we first have to look at the exact circumstances of the surveillance. No constitutional right's protection is absolute, after all, and…"*

Catra sighed and tried to ignore the convoluted talk on the TV in the mess hall. "If that's what they have for entertainment, the guards here are worse off than the prisoners," she muttered. While the supposed expert basically said that spying was OK if it was for a sufficiently important reason, she finished her fish sandwich - at least the food was good here.

"Thank you, John. And now, back to more international politics. Russia and China have released a joint declaration demanding that Earth's Stargate be placed beyond 'factional control' and not be militarised. The American government has refuted the proposal, stating that the Stargate was of critical military importance and crucial for the safety of Earth and announced to veto any decision of the Security Council that would…"

Catra rolled her eyes, not for the first time. How the United Nations got anything done when everyone could block everything was a miracle. And a reason not to underestimate the Seretary-General, she reminded herself. He did get at least some things done.

The door to the mess hall was opened - not the one to the outside, thankfully - and Catra smiled when she saw her love enter. Adora must have finally finished dealing with the prisoners. It had taken longer than usual, so something else than just ensuring Haken didn't die today must have come up.

Adora sighed as she sat down at the table, and Catra was sure that if they weren't in public, her lover would drop her forehead on the table. "What's wrong?" she asked.

Adora closed her eyes. "I was asked to bless people - the prisoners."

Catra frowned. "They needed your healing?" The prisoners shouldn't need healing unless more had lost their symbionts.

"No. Just to bless them." Adora sighed again. "More people, I mean. It's spreading."

"Ah." Catra shrugged. "Better they revere you than the Goa'uld."

Adora frowned at her. "Apparently, my 'dedication to keeping Haken alive' is swaying more Jaffa. But I'm not healing him to impress people! This feels like I'm abusing my power - and my position - to convert them!"

Catra shook her head. "You aren't, and you know it. Stop being an idiot. You're doing what's right, and people realise that. That's perfectly normal."

"Being worshipped isn't normal," Adora complained.

"I don't know," Catra retorted. "The Jaffa were raised to worship the Goa'uld as gods. And they focused on one particular Goa'uld, the one they were fighting for. So, it would only be natural for them to look for another god if they lose faith in their old one."

"You know what I mean!"

Catra grinned and flashed her fangs. "I think worshipping you is perfectly natural. I do it myself. Regularly."

Adora blushed. "Not… not like that!" She shook her head. "Anyway, let's go. We have to visit the saved prisoners before we're expected in Brussels."

"Alright."

*****

Temporary Refugee Housing, Travis Air Force Base, California, February 24th, 1999

The prisoners we've saved are living in worse conditions than the prisoners of war we've taken, Catra thought - not for the first time - as they entered the camp. For all that the Americans had offered to house the Iranians temporarily, they did so in tents. Better tents than the Horde used, of course, but that didn't mean too much.

And the area was under guard. Officially for the protection of the former prisoners, but Catra was sure that the guards were here as much to keep the people in the camp as to keep potential threats away. The base had a big clinic, which was part of the reason the Americans had picked this location, but Adora had healed the freed people anyway. Catra suspected that the Americans were hoping to recruit the suspected sorceresses from amongst the prisoners. Or just wanted to look good for taking in refugees or something. But it wasn't as if the Etherians had had many alternatives - or the time to ask for them.

"She-Ra!"

"She-Ra!"

Their arrival hadn't gone unnoticed, and people quickly rushed out of tents to welcome them.

Catra smiled a bit more toothily as they were crowded, but the mob didn't really back off. That's what they got for rescuing them, she guessed. At least none reached out to touch her or Adora, but they were so *loud* as they talked rapidly over each other. Catra didn't understand a word. Well, except 'She-Ra', which was repeated all the time.

And then one woman - a woman they had saved from Evin Prison, accused as a witch - fell down on her knees and bowed to Adora, and… Catra blinked as a number of the people surrounding them hissed and even cursed, moving away from the kneeling woman, while others stood their ground, and one woman joined the first. This was… "You're right," she told her lover as she understood what the woman was saying. "Your worship is spreading." It made kind of sense - Earth people, at least these people here, were raised to worship a god as well, after all.

Adora groaned.

*****

Cheyenne Mountain, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, February 25th, 1999

"..and contrary to Adora's… concerns, or certain media reports, two women converting to, ah, the Church of She-Ra doesn't indicate a general trend. In fact, judging by the generally very negative reaction amongst the rescued Iranian prisoners to what they see as a case of apostasy, I don't think we can expect a lot of people converting to worshipping Adora even amongst those she personally saved."

Jack O'Neill snorted at Daniel's summary. "That's one way to describe it. The base had to isolate the two women for their own protection." There hadn't been an actual attempt, last he heard, but there had been vocal *opinions*.

Daniel frowned at him. "I had to explain to Priest that they weren't being imprisoned for their faith. Fortunately, Adora was

present as well, and the two women have been released."

And were now, as far as Jack knew, the first Iranians in space. The Alliance would have to screen for spies amongst new converts once that tidbit got out; no spy agency would baulk at using that to insert people into the fleet. Priest claimed they were prepared, but Jack knew better than trusting a zealot's assurances.

"But would not the fact that, despite the Iranians' reactions, the two women chose to convert - and publicly - indicate that the appeal of the Church of She-Ra amongst the Tau'ri is greater than expected?" Teal'c asked.

"It's the hot new thing. Like New New Age," Jack replied with a shrug. "I guess it'll be really popular in Hollywood for a while." But he didn't think it would last. Just another fad.

Teal'c raised an eyebrow, and Daniel frowned and replied: "I don't think we should dismiss this so easily. The potential consequences of even minor incidents such as this… Conversion is a very sensitive subject for many religious people."

"Pretty much everything is a 'very sensitive subject' for those people," Jack retorted. "Even whether you use chunky or smooth peanut butter."

"Well, peanut butter isn't covered in scripture, but many religions have rules and taboos about food," Daniel said.

Jack rolled his eyes. "Whatever. The situation in Travis Air Force Base has been handled, and Earth wasn't bombarded by alien zealots in response. So, we came out ahead."

They could leave religious debates to the preachers. Jack was an Air Force officer, not a military chaplain.

*****

Earth Orbit, February 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and Jaleh Davani and Reyhan Turani have been assigned cabins on my flagship - I assume this meets with your approval, Your Divine Highness."

Priest was trying to hide his glee, but he wasn't doing a good job. Adora could tell. The clone was almost oozing satisfaction as he led her through the corridor of his ship, with clones bowing to her at every corner or, so it seemed.

She didn't like it.

But he was correct. Kind of. "As long as their presence won't impede fleet operations," she said. It was a bit petty, but a little reminder that they were at war and that civilians didn't have a place in war never hurt.

"Should we have to move out they will be transferred to a frigate of the task force guarding Earth," Priest replied. "Unless, of course, they would prefer to serve in Your fleet or army, Your Divine Highness. Both have a talent for magic."

Adora knew that. But neither of the two women had had any training. Military or magical. They'd need years of training. If you wanted to send untrained sorceresses - untrained civilians - into war, you might as well just kill them yourself. They would have to get training anyway, whether or not they wanted to fight in the war. But should she ask Castaspella for help? And would that be fair to all the other potential sorceresses on Earth? The last thing she wanted was for people to think that if they worshipped her, or fought in the war, they would receive training in magic. Or that if they worshipped her, they must fight in the war. "They know they don't have to serve, right?"

"Of course, Your Divine Highness!" Priest nodded. "No trickery or pressure shall be used to spread your faith!"

That wasn't exactly what she had meant, but it was a good - a very good - rule anyway. "Yes."

“Can’t have that,” Catra agreed, though a glance told Adora that her lover was grinning. As if this was funny!

“I’m no goddess,” she muttered. But could she tell the two women that? They had lost their home, their families, and they had risked their lives by abandoning their old faith. To tell them off, after everything they had suffered… Adora couldn’t do that. That would be too cruel.

“And here we are, Your Divine Highness!” Priest announced, pointing at two doors ahead of them, with a pair of clones standing guard between them.

“Good security,” Catra commented.

“They shouldn’t be left alone on the ship, being so new to Your flock,” Priest said with a nod.

Adora pressed her lips together. It felt wrong to keep guards on the two women after rescuing them from prison, but they had to consider the potential security risk both represented. Catra and Priest had insisted on that.

The guards bowed as well, and Adora nodded, reaching out to push the buzzer buttons next to both doors.

A few seconds later, the two doors opened almost simultaneously.

“Yes? Oh, Your Divine Highness!”

“She-Ra! I mean, Your Divine Highness!”

Both women gasped and bowed.

Adora froze for a moment, staring at them. Not because of their reaction - she had expected that. But they were wearing the same clothes as the clones in the fleet - and it reminded her far too much of what Catra had been wearing when she had been brainwashed by Horde Prime. When she had fought Adora and she had…

Behind her, she heard Catra hiss.

*****

Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, February 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Morrison apparently had decided to move in, turning a spare storeroom into a bedroom, Samantha Carter thought as she looked at the man working. And he got along a bit too much with Loki, in her opinion - the two scientists were lost in their work, bent over the latest results from the test tubes. Cell cultures, not anything more developed, of course.

"It feels good to see the base serving its original purpose again," Alpha commented. "Original research, expanding the knowledge of the First Ones, breaking new ground, creating what is, essentially, a new species based on another, lesser species…"

Sam glanced at the projection next to her. Alpha looked a bit too enthusiastic.

"Yes!" As did Entrapta, of course. "And we're also making progress on finding a solution for the Jaffa's immune system. That's trickier, of course - we can't just modify their genes so the next generation won't need the Goa'uld. Well, we could, but that would still leave so many without a working immune system."

"We've decided on a dual approach. Genetic engineering to remove the inherent weakness the Goa'uld created and a synthetic symbiont to replace the larvae," Alpha said. "There is some data from a failed project that should be able to serve as a base for the latter project."

"A failed project?" Sam asked.

"Yes. A project aimed at creating a biological, self-replicating weapon based on a macro-organism. It was deemed a failure since micro-organisms were more efficient and harder to detect

and defend against, but its method of attack and killing shows parallels to the Goa'uld."

They were working with a biological weapon? Styled after the Goa'uld? Sam suppressed a shudder as she remembered a particular science fiction movie.

"Oh! Was it based on the Goa'uld? Or inspired by them?" Entrapta asked.

"The latter. No Goa'uld genes were used for the organism. Which is unfortunate since that would have likely facilitated our current project," Alpha said.

It was 'unfortunate' that the First Ones hadn't created a bioweapon using a sapient species as a base? Sam was very glad that they didn't rely on the artificial intelligence to keep an eye on the researchers.

But they were making progress in their research, and that was what counted.

*****

Earth Orbit, February 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and the rooms are perfectly fine - more than fine, actually. To think we're on a starship, above Earth… the views are beautiful. I know it's a screen, not a window, but I also know we are in space, so that's… almost the same. And the bed is fine as well, Your Divine Highness."

Catra fought the urge to check her neck. Horde Prime was dead. His mind-control chip had been removed. She was free. She was fine. She was doing fine. And if Adora didn't stop glancing at her every minute as if she wanted to hug her and pat her head, then she'd demonstrate just how fine she was. With her claws.

She forced herself to ignore the glances and stared at the two women, the two sorceresses, they had saved from Evin Prison.

Jaleh Davani and Reyhan Turani. They needed help. Catra was fine. She wasn't effectively exiled from her own country on pain of death - twice over, actually. Once for being sorceresses and once for having changed their religion. Hell, they couldn't even trust their fellow former inmates because even some people who had been in prison with the two might kill them for that.

It was a very fucked-up situation. And Adora and Catra were here to do something about that. "So, you've settled in fine here," Catra said as soon as Jaleh had finished. She added a glance at Adora to remind her lover what they were here for.

"Yes," Reyhan said. "We're very grateful for your generosity, Your Divine Highness."

"Ah, I'm…" Adora trailed off. "We're doing what we can. It wouldn't do to save you and then just… leave you. We aren't leaving the others, of course, but they are not… in as much need as you are."

"To help those in need when and where you can is what we strive for. Just as you showed us, Your Divine Highness," Jaleh said. Both women nodded with shining eyes and wide smiles.

Adora's smile slipped a tiny bit. Catra could tell she was internally wincing. "That's… a good ideal, yes," her lover said. "But don't feel that you have to do this, you don't have to follow me, just to get help. That's not how things work."

"Priest has explained that, Your Divine Highness," Reyhan said.

"Do not give only so you shall receive; only what is freely given is a real gift," Jaleh added with a slow nod. Catra could hear Priest's voice in her quote. "We know, Your Divine Highness. But we want to help. We want to be better than those who threatened and hurt us. We want to make the world a better place. The greater your means, the greater your responsibility."

Reyhan nodded once again. "We have the talent, the magic, to make a difference, and so we want to, we have to, use it to help

others."

Catra nodded with a sly smile. There wasn't much Adora could say against that without being a hypocrite. "But you need the training to actually do something with your talent," she said.

"Yes," Adora nodded. "Without training, you can't do much."

Whether as sorceresses or as soldiers, Catra thought. During the Horde War, the Princess Alliance had found out that guts and knowledge of the terrain only went so far. And the Alliance against the Goa'uld wouldn't be fighting in Iran. Well, not unless the Iranians went completely crazy.

"I looked into… magic," Reyhan said. "I studied old tales, old books. I only found some curses, though. And some old folks remedies that didn't seem to work."

She didn't say whether she had tried any of those curses, Catra noted.

"Yes," Jaleh added, nodding twice. "What I found didn't work - it was mostly prayers."

The way the two looked at Adora… Catra shook her head, snorting softly.

As expected, her lover caved in. "Well, if you don't know Earth magic - your own magic - we can get you training on Etheria. I'll have to ask Castaspella, but she mentioned a while ago that she would like to work with and teach an Earth sorcerer."

Meaning, Castaspella would have liked to teach O'Neill, Catra thought. She doubted that these two had the same talent as O'Neill had; they weren't First Ones - they had been tested for that. But still, she didn't think Castaspella would refuse to teach them.

"And we can teach others," Jaleh said. "Both magic and how to do good in your name, Your Divine Highness."

Yeah, Catra thought as Adora winced a little, Priest has been busy. The clone obviously wasn't going to waste this opportunity.

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Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, February 26th, 1999

"...and so you and your team will report to Alliance Headquarters in Brussels at the earliest opportunity. Quarters in the city have been arranged, although given your unique circumstances, it is in doubt whether or not you'll use them often, I suppose."

Jack O'Neill glanced at the written orders he had received to confirm this, then nodded. That's what you did when you received legal orders from your superior, and short of the Commander-in-Chief himself, the Secretary of Defense was pretty much the highest authority. And shouldn't actually hand out redeployment orders for a mere Colonel and his team - that would have been General Hammond's job as Jack's commanding officer. And it should have happened in Colorado Springs. Not Washington D.C.

Which told Jack all he needed to know that this was a political thing. Of course, SG-1 was going to be reassigned to the Alliance forces; Jack had known that for months - ever since Stargate Command had been put under United Nations control, at least officially. But he hadn't expected it to happen so soon - they were still preparing the move to the new gate location. Carter had just sorted out another problem with her future lab.

And speaking of that… "What about lab spaces for my team members?" he asked.

"Captain Carter has her spacelab, hasn't she? She is usually off-wold anyway, according to your reports." The Secretary of Defense shrugged. "I am sure Dr Jackson will have ample office space for his records."

They were fine with Carter spending more time off-world, meaning, with the Etherians? Where she could, should she want

to, ignore any orders from command? Not that Carter would, of course, but, in Jack's experience, the military and the government liked to have more control over critically important assets such as her.

So why were they doing this?

"This is unexpected," he commented.

The Secretary of Defense snorted. "Unexpected? After the mess in Iran? The Russians and the Chinese aren't quite screaming bloody murder, but they've made it clear that Stargate Command members fighting the Goa'uld with the Alliance was one thing, but intervening in a sovereign country on Earth without a United Nations mandate was another thing altogether."

"We were observers. We didn't do anything to help that intervention," Jack snapped.

The other man snorted again. "And that's the official stance of our government. But we had to do something to placate them anyway."

"What could they do?" Jack asked. "The Alliance outnumbers them in the Command Council, and we can veto anything they try in the United Nations." He didn't have to mention that, with the Etherians casually confirming that they wouldn't let a nuclear war happen, the Alliance didn't have to fear either country - or the rest of the world - at all.

That earned him a glare. "Don't play the fool, Colonel! You know that politics aren't that simple. They never are."

Jack wanted to make a few comments about all the legitimacy coming out of the barrels of guns but managed to hold his tongue. He didn't agree with the man either, though.

After a moment, the Secretary of Defense scoffed. "Sooner or later, the Russians and the Chinese, and a number of other countries, will get advanced technology. The Cold War taught us

that. You can't use technology and keep it secret at the same time."

We've managed quite well at Stargate Command. Until we met the Etherians, Jack thought.

"And we don't really want half the world hating our guts by the time they get that technology. We're still dealing with the fallout from keeping the Stargate a secret." The man scowled as if that had been Jack's fault - it was his government that had decided to keep it a secret. The Secretary himself had supported and enforced this policy!

"They would still take decades to catch up," Jack said.

"We can't be sure," the Secretary of Defense retorted. "We're facing the biggest war the world has ever seen. We don't know how long it will take. We don't know what it will do to our and the world's economy. Hell, we don't know what advanced technology and contact with aliens will do to our society. But we know that the World Wars reshaped the world and the United States - and that this war will be worse. So, we can't just antagonise the rest of the world," he repeated himself.

"Did anyone tell the Etherians that?" Jack asked before he could help himself. Well, he could only control himself so much.

The man's scowl deepened. "As you are surely aware, Colonel, the Etherians value human rights above long-term geostrategic concerns."

And you don't, Jack thought. "Must be annoying."

Another glare was aimed at him. Jack tried to look innocent. "Long-term, the Etherians are unlikely to keep their currently dominant position," the man told him. "Proliferation of advanced technology, coupled with our demographic advantage, ensures that. We have to plan ahead with this in mind."

Jack had no doubt that the man, and a great number of other people, were looking forward to that day. He wasn't sure how to feel about that himself. Being a distant second power wasn't fun, but the Etherians, at least the Princess Alliance, were honest, straightforward and generally plain *good* people. Jack wasn't sure if he wanted to see the typical politicians replace them as the top dogs.

But he was sure that mentioning that would be very, very foolish. "So, the Russians and Chinese will be satisfied with us being removed from Stargate Command?"

"They will have to be satisfied with the United States having taken the necessary steps to ensure that Stargate Command is not perceived as taking sides in international conflicts," the man replied. "That's how we're framing this." The man grinned. "Of course, everyone knows that they would prefer to keep SG-1 under their command."

Especially Carter. Jack nodded. Still, there were a few open questions left. "Dr Jackson will be hired as a consultant by the Alliance?"

The man shrugged. "Unless the Etherians want to hire him directly. Or adopt him. His insight has proven valuable in the past in a variety of situations."

That sounded like an excuse, but Jack wasn't about to complain that he got to keep his friend on his team. "And Teal'c as well, I suppose."

"Yes. The Etherians have a tradition of coopting former enemies, as far as we know, so they should be fine with this."

It didn't look as if the man cared for Teal'c, and what Jack's friend had done for them and Earth. Well, as long as it kept the team together…

Jack nodded. So, that was it. The end of his time at Stargate Command. And the official start of his time in the Alliance forces.

He didn’t quite know how to feel about this. But it didn’t matter. He had his orders. And a war to fight in. He knew his duty.

*****

Nine Months Later

Above Brussels Spaceport, Zaventem, Belgium, October 25th, 1999

"Alliance-One, this is Brussels Space Traffic Control. Please stay at your assigned position while we clear a route to your destination."

"Brussels Space Traffic Control, copy. Holding." Adora checked their position and that the autopilot was running with the new instructions, then leaned back.

"We should have taken a stealth shuttle directly to Headquarters. We wouldn't have to deal with all the traffic here."

Adora sighed at Catra's complaint. "We can't just interrupt the air and space traffic over Belgium for our convenience."

"Of course, we could! We have the override codes."

"They're meant for an emergency. Not to avoid a bit of a delay." Usually, it took less than ten minutes of waiting before they could continue to the Alliance Headquarters.

"It's a pointless delay. Why are they making us wait? You're the Supreme Commander of the Alliance; you take priority." Catra twisted on the seat next to Adora and put her feet up on the armrest while her tail sneaked around to brush over Adora's arm.

"Brussels is a key part of the shuttle network," Adora replied, grabbing the tip of the tail and pushing it back. She was piloting! "We would disrupt their schedule, causing delays in many, many different flights." Catra knew that - she had been involved in the logistics of the Alliance. But Adora's lover loved to complain over minor things.

Catra perked up with a grin. "That would teach them how to handle delays from battles and attacks! Let's do it and call it training!"

“We’re already training for such interruptions in our exercises,” Adora reminded her. “We don’t need to disrupt actual supply flights for that.”

“Most of the flights are just people getting shuttled around,” Catra retorted. “I bet our meeting would be much less of a pain if half of the officers didn’t make it to it!”

That would be… No! Adora pressed her lips together. It would be irresponsible! “This is an important meeting about the state of readiness of the Alliance forces.”

“You’ve read the same reports I read,” Catra retorted. “We already know how ready they are. Hell, we’ve always known.”

Of course, they knew. But this was about doing something to improve the state of readiness of their forces. And it was better to give the necessary orders in person and directly to the people responsible.

She looked at the sensor screen. Dozens of shuttles were launching and landing, with more on the way. Brussels Spaceport - renamed from Brussels Airport months ago; Adora had been at the ceremony - was one of the busiest spaceports. Well, one of the busiest civilian spaceports, even if most of the traffic was Alliance business. The major Alliance bases were far busier.

An alert popped up on the screen. Catra frowned and reached over. “Oh. It’s the Fighting Flower.”

“HMS Gladiolus,” Adora corrected her. The first Earth-built spaceship was currently flying at medium altitude over the Channel. Probably one of the last test flights before her official shakedown cruise.

“That’s a stupid name,” Catra retorted. “Everyone’s calling her the Fighting Flower.”

‘Everyone’ mostly being the British media.

“The Royal Navy named the ship,” Adora said. As the lead ship of the Flower II-class of corvettes, she had been named after the first ship of the original Flower-class, or so Adora had been told by Admiral Hood, who had overseen the design from start to finish.

“Should have picked a better name. But I guess they want to save those for bigger ships.” Catra shrugged. “Can’t really name a ship that’s barely bigger than a large transport shuttle ‘Warspite’ or ‘Victory’, can you?”

Adora frowned. The class was quite a bit bigger than a shuttle. But it was also much smaller than a Horde frigate. About as large as Darla, actually. It wouldn’t do well against a Ha’Tak, but according to their tests, it would do well fighting Al’Keshs and would be able to deal with squadrons of Death Gliders. And that was its intended purpose - escorting larger ships, especially the fleet transports that were being built, and screening capital ships in battles from bombers and fighters.

Before she could say anything, though, the main screen lit up - Brussels space traffic control had sent them their route.

“Finally! Let’s go!” Catra grinned and leaned forward.

Adora nodded and took the controls. A moment later, they were on the way to the Alliance Headquarters.

Their usual landing pad, protected by a separate shield generator so landing shuttles wouldn’t render the main building defenceless, was free, and Adora put the shuttle down easily. “Don’t let them know you flew the shuttle,” Catra said as she got up from her seat. “You know how they are about that.”

Adora rolled her eyes. Some people thought she was setting a bad example for others - a surprisingly high number of flag officers wanted to qualify for shuttles, they had found out - but she liked flying. And you never knew when you had to pilot a shuttle or ship in battle.

To Adora’s happy surprise, they were greeted at the ramp by Jack.

He sketched a salute that had the German officer in charge of the guards at the pad frowning. "Welcome to Brussels, Supreme Commander."

Adora returned the salute. "General."

"Don't remind me!"

Catra snickered at his comment. "If you really want to return to being a lowly Colonel, we can surely find a reason to demote you. I bet a lot of people would be happy, too."

"Yeah, especially the Navy pukes," Jack muttered with a scowl. "How they got to take over our space program after messing up our building program so the limeys beat us…"

As far as Adora knew, confirmed by Sam, the struggle between the Air Force and the Navy had been the main reason for the delays in the American shipbuilding program that saw their project, the Constitution II-class of frigates, fall behind schedule. But mentioning that would only annoy Jack almost as much as...

"Well, we could promote you to Admiral," Catra suggested.

...reminding him that the United States Navy was responsible for their space fleet would.

Adora sighed at her lover while Jack scowled even more. She could only hope the upcoming meeting would go more smoothly.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, October 26th, 1999

"I've sent you the revised blueprints for the turrets a week ago, sir."

"Yes, yes, but there have been a few issues at the yard, resulting in changes to the turret layouts. We need modified blueprints,

Major." The officer on her screen smiled apologetically. Or faked it well enough so Samantha Carter couldn't tell if he actually felt sorry or not.

Another change of the specifications! For a ship that was already being built! She clenched her teeth for a moment, swallowing a rather inappropriate comment - at least for a freshly promoted Major addressing a flag-rank officer. As one of the leading scientists of the Alliance, she probably would get away with voicing her frustration with the entire design process, but it would still be unprofessional. "I see," she said in a flat tone.

"Yes. You can get the details from the report I'm mailing you, but it's basically the power lines again."

"That design point was finalised a month ago, sir." After two months of bickering about the specs while the hull had already been laid down and was being built!

"Yes, but the yard noticed a problem with the torpedo launchers."

Sam narrowed her eyes. That shouldn't affect the design of the *gun* turrets.

"Anyway, you can check the report. It's all in there. We need the revised blueprints as soon as possible." The admiral grimaced. *"The Royal Navy launching their spaceship before we do hasn't gone over well with Congress. Or the public. We need to catch up - or beat them with commissioning the first ship."*

"The Flower II-class are corvettes, sir," Sam reminded him. "Not frigates." Or a 'heavy frigate', or an 'armed escort carrier' or whatever else the committee responsible for the specifications for the first American spaceship had come up with for a design that was trying to have both the firepower of a Horde frigate and the ability to carry a squadron of starfighters without the necessary size for both. "They are much smaller and, therefore, quicker to build." And to fit out, and to commission.

And the corvette's design hadn't been hindered by the struggle between the Air Force and the Navy over which branch would control the space fleet. Sam still felt angry about all the bickering she had seen. And the petty power plays. How General Naird could have thought that calling in favours in Congress to have the design named 'Constitution II-class' would somehow help to keep the whole thing an Air Force project was still a mystery to her. All it ensured was that the Constitution II-class wouldn't actually include a ship named 'Constitution' since the Navy still had the original sailing frigate named so commissioned.

Not for the first time, she wondered if she should have been more involved with the design. But between her crucial work with Entrapta and her involvement in the joint starfighter project, there simply hadn't been any time for that.

And, a small voice in the back of her head that sounded suspiciously like the Colonel's - the Generals', she reminded herself - she couldn't have let the Air Force down. Not after the Air Force had lost the struggle for control over the fleet and was left with handling all starfighters that weren't based on carriers or space stations.

But perhaps she could have made the ship designers understand that they should have focused on a gun and missile frigate or a light carrier, not a combination of both. The Horde frigates carried fighters, but only a flight of three, and they were crewed by bots, which also did most of the maintenance. Which cut down on crew requirements.

"Anyway, just send us the revised blueprints tomorrow at the latest, alright?"

Sam nodded. "Unless more critical issues crop up, sir." She was doing more important work than trying to fix mistakes other people kept making. At least the fleet transports were coming along on schedule. Mostly.

"Good." The call ended, and the picture faded from view.

Sam sighed and leaned back, closing her eyes for a moment. She really didn't need that. She had so much else to do.

She glanced at her notes. She hadn't been able to work on the alien data cube in months. And she was still behind on the latest spy bot version. And…

An alert on her screen interrupted her thoughts. An incoming call from Entrapta? Sam accepted at once, smiling already.

"Hi, Sam!" Her friend's face appeared on the screen, beaming at her. She was in the research station; Sam could tell from the background.

"Hello, Entrapta."

"You need to head to Etheria immediately!" her friend announced.

It couldn't be an emergency - Entrapta was happy. So… "The synthetic Prim'ta is ready for final testing?" Sam asked. That was a game-changer. They would be able to offer freedom from the Goa'uld to the Jaffa.

"Yes! It's ready for the final testing! So, get Haken and bring him over! I've already called Adora, in case something goes wrong."

Not that anything should go wrong - the preliminary tests were successful, and the projections had been correct so far. But you could never be sure. Sam nodded and called up the forms she had prepared. "I'll be there as soon as I can get Haken."

"Great! Loki's getting a tiny bit impatient, but he'll be happy to hear that!"

Of course, the Asgard was impatient - he expected them to drop everything else and focus on fixing the Asgard's genome as soon as the synthetic Prim'ta checked out.

Of course, that would be preferable to being dragged into yet another design folly, Sam thought as she ended the call and got

up.

But before she could get to the door, her phone rang.

Half an hour, and another problem later, she had to cancel her visit to Etheria.

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Bright Moon, Etheria, October 26th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Luna had grown up so much! Catra couldn't help feeling proud of the little kitten. Or not so little kitten any more. She had managed to not only escape their room in the palace again - which was to be expected, of course; you couldn't cage a cat - but she had also managed to strike a blow against the true enemy: paperwork.

"Don't smile at the little monster!"

And she had annoyed Sparkles, which was always a bonus. Catra ignored the huffing and took Luna from Glimmer's hands. "There you are! Did you have a good hunt?" she asked as she held her up.

Luna started to wriggle in her hands, squirming until she could climb over Catra's arms to her shoulders.

"She destroyed the latest training reports from our forces!" Glimmer said with a frown. "Shredded them all over my office."

"So? You've got them on your tablet. Just print them out again if you don't want to read them on the screen," Catra dismissed the complaint while scratching Luna's head. She would have expected Bow's lover to be more comfortable with technology, anyway. "Besides, it's not going to be anything we don't know already: The units we formed from veterans of the Horde war are ready. And the rest aren't."

Glimmer's frown deepened. "There are still the problems between the former Horde and veteran Princess Alliance soldiers to be

addressed."

Catra shrugged, suppressing the slight pang of guilt she felt. "Send them against the Goa'uld. Nothing makes soldiers bond faster than a baptism of fire." As long as they won the battle, of course, or they would blame each other, but since the Goa'uld still hadn't realised that Earth had formed an alliance with Etheria, Catra doubted they would lose the next battle. They had surprise, could pick their target and mass overwhelming forces. If they lost despite those advantages, well… they would have more important problems to deal with than some bad blood within the Princess Alliance.

"That would require us to actually go on the offensive," Glimmer retorted. "And stop dithering around."

Ah, Sparkles was still a firebrand. Catra shrugged. "Tell it to the Tok'ra." Their spies were working on finding the most vulnerable target. Or so they claimed. They had been working on that for months now. They probably had some trouble adjusting to the fact that they weren't limited to operating in the shadows any more.

Glimmer scoffed. "If they shared their data, we could have our own analysts working on that."

But that would put the Tok'ra's spies at risk if anything leaked. It wasn't a concern right now, but once the war picked up steam… Catra shrugged again, wincing a little when Luna's claws dug into her upper arm as the kitten reacted to the movement. "Careful! My fur's not as tough as my uniform!"

Luna ignored her and started to climb down her back before jumping off and dashing towards her favourite nap spot. Well, her third-favourite nap spot after Catra and Adora's laps.

Girl had good taste.

"When will Adora be back?" Glimmer asked, changing the topic.

"When we know if the synthetic snake works and Adora can stop travelling to Earth every day to heal Jaffa," Catra replied. "I don't know how long that will take." It also was another obstacle to going on the offensive. Adora couldn't really lead a campaign on another planet across the sector if she had to heal Jaffa prisoners every day. Well, she could, but that would mean letting prisoners die, and Adora would never do that. And letting someone else lead the offensive… well, who else could do it? Glimmer, maybe, but she wasn't as good at it as Adora. Hordak would be able to, but that would cause problems with the Etherians. And his personality wouldn't go over well with the Tau'ri. Netossa was smart enough, but she lacked the experience. And the same went for the Earth officers.

And, she couldn't help thinking, I could do it. If I hadn't been responsible for the Horde almost conquering Etheria and causing so much pain and misery to everyone…

"Anyway, what's new from our favourite thorn in our side?" she asked to change the subject.

"Queen Bee or her visitors?" Glimmer shot back.

"Both," Catra replied.

"We don't know the exact details. But the talks seem to have hit an obstacle," Glimmer said. "At least according to our sources."

Which were rather limited. If only they could trust Double-Trouble… But you couldn't trust that drama queen, as the Americans would call them. "So, still no Chinese or Russian invasion. Pity - that would be a good training exercise." Catra grinned.

"Don't joke about invasions," Glimmer objected.

"Why not?" Catra doubted that anything would come of the talks, anyway. Queen Bee wouldn't risk upsetting most of her fickle allies by allowing the 'princess murderers' into her kingdom. Even though the Russian princesses hadn't had any magic powers and

hadn’t protected their people, it struck a chord with Etherians. Especially after the Horde War. Releasing the information about the Russian Revolution had been a good idea.

Glimmer scoffed instead of answering. “They’re still going to open trade relations; we’re sure of that. And the rest of Earth is pushing for tourism.”

“They should worry about fixing their economy,” Catra retorted. She wasn’t an expert, far from it, but she had read about the situation, and while none of the experts agreed with each other about everything, especially whether or not the ‘bubble’, as they called it, from the build-up for the war was a good thing in the long run, all were agreeing that Earth’s economy was facing trouble.

Glimmer shrugged. “I don’t think that the people who want to visit Etheria from Earth in the middle of a war have the right priorities.”

“Yeah.”

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Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, October 26th, 1999

“...and that’s the typical community formed by the human slaves of the Goa’uld. However, as I said before, this is just a general model; actual societies will vary greatly depending on the individual Goa’uld and even on individual planets. Any concrete interaction with them will have to be based on detailed information gathered on location. Although there are similarities, especially with regard to religion. Are there any questions?”

It was a good thing, Jack O’Neill thought as he watched Daniel’s lesson from the back of the classroom, that the Hollywood cliches were wrong about special forces. His friend’s lecture would have been fit for a university course. At least in his opinion. But, as with Stargate Command, the Alliance got the cream of the crop for

their special forces, so the soldiers present, all of them officers, would have been able to follow the lesson. Or should have.

One, a British officer, Lieutenant Clarke, raised his hand. "So, we are supposed to observe any community covertly before making contact?"

"Ideally, yes." Daniel smiled. "Although sometimes, that isn't possible. Or there's an emergency that forces us to make contact. We've had a few of those in the past."

Clarke didn't seem to be convinced. "You stressed that honesty and trust were crucial for opening good relations with such societies. Observing them from hiding doesn't seem to be conducive to either."

Daniel sighed. "Yes. But some of those societies are, well, thoroughly indoctrinated, and they might react violently to us contacting them. It is essential to spot such dangers beforehand. Fortunately, just knowing which god they worship usually provides us with enough information to recognise such dangers."

Usually.

"And your lecture will teach us how to spot such dangers?" The slight French accent of the next officer, Capitain Colbert, didn't hide his scepticism.

"That's the goal, yes." Daniel nodded. "Of course, we can't cover everything a university course would, but we'll cover all known Goa'uld gods."

"False gods," Lieutenant Mills, former Green Beret, muttered.

Daniel frowned at the comment. "Yes, we call them false gods. But remember: These people have been raised to worship their Goa'uld overlords as gods. This is a core part of their identity. If you think you'll be able to convince them that their religion is built on lies and that they are exploited by false gods with a few speeches, you would be mistaken."

Colbert snorted. “If that worked, the Vatican would be a museum.”

Half the room snickered, though several of the officers present looked annoyed or even offended. Jack frowned and memorised their names. If they took offence at such comments, they might not have the right mindset to deal with people who honestly worshipped pagan gods. Or, he added with a silent snort, work with clones who worshipped She-Ra.

Daniel, though, nodded. “That’s a very good example, actually. Don’t think of those people as the victims of a scam who only need to be told the truth to accept it. Think of them as deeply devout Christians or Muslims. They will not convert easily - or at all - no matter how good you think your arguments are.”

“But they’re worshipping snakes! Parasites!” Mills protested. “We can prove that - we can show them their gods are fake!”

Jack added his name to his list.

“Are they?” Daniel cocked his head and looked at Mills. “What’s your definition of a god, Lieutenant?”

Mills opened his mouth, then closed it. “I know what’s not a god,” he said. “And a Goa’uld isn’t a god.”

Daniel nodded. “Those people have a different view. Yes, they are slaves, toiling in often cruel conditions for their overlords, but many, if not most of them, have seen their gods, and seen them demonstrate what they consider divine powers. If they worship a smart Goa’uld, they have even seen people getting healed by their ‘gods’ or receiving ‘blessings’ and gifts. And they haven’t heard of any alternatives - sometimes, they don’t even know there are other Goa’uld, though that’s rarer. In order to subvert them, you will have to move very carefully and find those of them open to turn against their gods. Those willing to blame their gods for their suffering. Those who have lost family or lovers to the whims of their overlords, those who won’t simply accept the gods’ words as

true but question them." He sighed. "And for that, the Goa'uld's cruelty works for us. There are many people ruled by them who will accept an alternative to living under a cruel god."

Most of the officers nodded, Jack noted.

"But there are also many who will cling to their faith no matter how much they suffer under the Goa'uld. They think they will be rewarded in the afterlife for it. Those people will attack you in order to prove their loyalty and faith - or they'll try to trick and betray you. Never forget that you are trying to turn people against who they think is their god and has power over their very souls."

"Well, no one ever said our mission would be easy," Burke commented with a shrug.

Most of the room nodded along.

Jack recognised the bravado. He'd say the same in Burke's place. And had done so, back when he was doing similar missions behind the enemy lines, sometimes literally. Burke was a veteran. And he had fought zombies. He could back that attitude up. Few of the others had experience with aliens or magic. But they were veterans as well, Jack reminded himself.

And they were his responsibility. He was in charge of the entire Alliance Special Operations Command. As a brigadier-general. If not for Adora and Glimmer making it absolutely clear to the brass that this wouldn't bar Jack from the field, he would have refused. Probably - the thought of the same people who sent him on missions back in the Cold War now being in charge of those soldiers here made him ill.

Which was why he had called on Daniel to give this lecture instead of wasting his time with academics. He wouldn't send his people out into the galaxy unless they had the best gear and training for their job. It wasn't Stargate Command, but that was no reason to have laxer standards.

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“This felt like my first time in front of students as an assistant back at university,” Daniel said once the soldiers had filed out and Jack O’Neill had joined him at the front - after making another note of who had been startled by his presence; soldiers in this business needed to be aware of their surroundings at all times.

“Oh?” Jack tilted his head to the side. “I would have thought this bunch was more disciplined.”

“What? Yes, they were, but what I meant was having you watching from the back, like my professor then.”

“Ah.” Jack grinned. “Well, I had to ensure you wouldn’t scare them off.”

Daniel snorted. “Every anecdote from our missions I told them just made them more eager.”

“That’s because they thought you were exaggerating.”

His friend blinked. “What?”

Jack shrugged. “You’re an academic. A civilian.” Technically - Daniel had more combat experience than most of the soldiers in the Alliance. “They’re the big bad special forces. The best of the best of the best,” he added in a fake imitation of a gung-ho drill sergeant. “Of course, what you think is scary couldn’t be really scary.”

“I didn’t say it was scary!” Daniel protested.

“That’s even worse. What doesn’t scare the bookworm polishing his glasses while lecturing them can’t possibly scare them, can it? It’s the same with Jaffa; until Teal’c personally demonstrates just what he can do, the soldiers still think this is going to be a reenactment of Zulu, with them as the British soldiers.”

“That should make them more cautious. The British forces were defeated decisively at the Battle of Isandlwana,” Daniel said with a slight pout.

Jack laughed. “They’re thinking of Rorke’s Drift and the movie. Anyway. Thank you for doing this. And not, you know, holing up in an ivory tower and rewriting every book about ancient history. Or taking over Harward or something.” He wasn’t a scientist, but he had been keeping an eye on the various attempts to poach Daniel. Some deans were playing downright dirty. Of course, Jack knew that as long as Sha’re was still in the hands of the Goa’uld, his friend wouldn’t even think of leaving for the university circuit, but still…

Daniel chuckled. “I’ve already sent the papers I wrote during our time at Stargate Command to get published. If I want to write a book, I can base it on that. Though I guess some of my esteemed colleagues will try to beat me to the punch, probably using my material. But none of them have my first-hand experience. They might still spot something I’ve missed, of course, as they go over all the exhibits and samples in their collections and reexamine them in light of their new knowledge. We’ve been focusing on Egypt, but the Babylonian connection seems promising as well, given what we know about the Goa’uld.”

Once they hit Babylonia, it was high time to change the subject. Jack nodded. “Yeah, sure. And speaking of Babylonia, did you have time to go over the list of linguists I’ve mailed you?”

“I did, but I am not really the best person to judge their ability to go on field missions,” Daniel said. “All of them should be skilled enough to handle the linguist work, though.”

“And that’s all I need. I’ve got people sorting out the rest,” Jack said. As a general, he had a lot of people for everything, but some things Jack couldn’t leave to anyone but those he’d trust with his life. “And what’s your impression of your temporary students here?”

“Do you mean academically?” Daniel asked.

“I mean whatever comes to mind.”

"Ah. Well, they grasped the core concept, but I can't tell yet if they'll apply it."

Jack nodded. They'd better, or they'd be sorry. Or dead. If they were lucky.

"They understood what I was telling them, but…" Daniel winced a little.

"Yes?" Jack tilted his head at him.

"Some might not have the attitude to work with people who have been worshipping the Goa'uld for all their lives," Daniel said. "I mean, they aren't nearly as bad as the missionaries we had to deal with, of course. Just..." He shrugged. "A bit too sure of their own beliefs."

"I noticed," Jack said. "I'll look into it." Fortunately, he only had to deal with special forces. He didn't envy the poor bastards in Alliance High Command who had to deal with the whole mess. Proselytising wasn't allowed, but as Priest had pointed out, they couldn't prohibit soldiers from talking about their beliefs if asked. Not if they wanted to deal honestly with the liberated slaves and aliens.

He checked his watch. "So, we've got twenty minutes before your course on alien cultures. Want to get some coffee? We can call Teal'c as well."

Daniel nodded. "As long as we go to the canteen and not to your office."

"My coffee maker is great," Jack protested. He had gone to some lengths to have the coffee maker from Stargate Command get officially 'lost in transit' during the move to the new gate location. "You never complained back in the Mountain."

"Jack! We're in Europe! They've got real coffee here!"

"We're in Germany. That's beer country, not coffee country."

“We’ve got French and Italian forces training here,” Daniel shot back. “And they’d mutiny if they had to deal with your coffee.”

“Hey! At least my coffee doesn’t cost more than a Happy Meal,” Jack shot back.

“And that’s how it tastes.” Daniel grinned and turned to leave the room before Jack could think of a good comeback.

Well, he’d get even later.

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Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, October 26th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“...and now we’ll see if it works or not!”

“It will work - our projections are flawless and have been verified through testing. We are merely awaiting confirmation of our results.”

“That’s what I said, Loki! You can’t be sure until you test it!”

“If your research is sound - and ours is - and your calculations are correct - and mine are - then you already know the outcome of an experiment. This is just to reassure those who lack the knowledge and intellect to understand science.”

“Models and projections are not a replacement for testing and experiments. Any true scientist would know that.”

“That seems a little harsh, Hordak. Dependable models can and should save time and effort, speeding up any research project. We would never have advanced as far as we did if we had tested everything with experiments.”

They hadn’t tested everything? Adora winced at Morrison’s comment. She wasn’t an expert - though she wasn’t an idiot either! - but when it came to genetic engineering, everything

should be tested thoroughly before you experimented on people. You shouldn't experiment on people, period, she corrected herself. "You didn't test everything?" she asked, glancing at Haken, who was in a tube getting scanned. Maybe she should summon her sword in case he required emergency healing…

"We did test every big step, just not every little step or toe-tip," Entrapta replied. "So, this is as safe as it can be before live testing! Which we are doing now!"

"Though I have to point out that not using multiple test subjects, including a control group, is less than ideal." Alpha had appeared next to them.

"We already know what happens if a Jaffa doesn't have a Prim'ta," Hordak said. "They die."

"Was that tested? Or merely modelled?" Loki cocked his head.

That sounded like a snide comment… Yes, everyone else was frowning, pouting, glaring or sighing at Loki, Adora saw.

"Loki! We already have experimental data showing what happens to Jaffa without a Prim'ta!" Entrapta scolded him. "They lose their immune system. Haken is proof of that."

"And we are sure that, unless stopped by outside intervention, this will lead to his death. Just as we know that this synthetic replacement will work." Loki lifted his chin.

"We'll see!" Hordak spat. He seemed annoyed enough to hope it wouldn't work, in Adora's opinion.

She looked at Mermista, who was sitting at a table in the back, either doing paperwork or watching something on her tablet - she was wearing the headphones Bow had designed. Probably an Earth TV show, the way she snickered and didn't pay attention to the discussion in front of her.

Well, one way to find out.

Adora left the scientists bickering and walked over to her friend. Who was, as she could see with a glance, watching an Earth show Adora didn't know. Probably a crime show, based on her friend's tastes. "Mermista?"

"Huh?" Mermista blinked, then quickly paused the show and turned to face Adora. "Yes? Do you need to go to the bathroom and need me to watch the gang again?"

"What? No!" Adora shook her head. "I was just wondering…" She leaned over and lowered her voice. "Are they always like that?"

"Hm?" Mermista glanced at the others, then nodded. "Ugh, yes."

Adora winced. Maybe she should have done some shifts as their supervisor herself, but she had been so busy leading the Alliance…

"Is that all?" Mermista asked.

Adora frowned. "Is something wrong?"

"No, I just want to finish this episode before you finish your tests."

"Ah, OK." Adora nodded.

Mermista was back to watching her show before Adora had turned away.

Maybe we should have been a bit more cautious with importing Earth media, Adora thought. Though that wouldn't have stopped Mermista, of course - as a princess, she had access to Earth media anyway. And Bow wouldn't have kept his 'emulator' that allowed tablets to show Earth shows secret, either. Maybe…

"OK, here comes the data!" Entrapta interrupted her thoughts. "And it looks good! No sign of any diseases taking hold."

That was good! Adora smiled. This was working, then! Haken's life wouldn't depend on her any more!

“Alright. Standing by for stress testing. First sample: Various bacteria,” Hordak announced.

Stress testing? Adora blinked.

“Hit him!” Entrapta beamed and turned to Adora. “Oh, better keep ready, in case we overestimated Jaffa resilience. Even with a working immune system, some of the stress tests might overwhelm him.”

“What?”

“They won’t,” Loki snapped. “Our models are correct.”

“What are you doing?” Adora asked.

“Exposing him to various pathogens so we can see how his immune system reacts,” Entrapta explained. “Basically, all the most common pathogens we know!”

“Ah…”

Adora hastily summoned her sword. Thorough testing also had some drawbacks, it seemed.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, October 26th, 1999

“...and all the data checked out, as you’d say: The Synthetic Symbiote is a success!” Entrapta beamed from where she sat on Samantha Carter’s desk, hair tendrils rearranging a few files and one sample from an asteroid that might be a good source of rare ore while she kicked the air with her feet. “Haken showed no degradation of his immune response at all. Adora didn’t even have to heal him when we used viruses that would overwhelm human immune systems. We didn’t test biological weapons, though.”

Sam froze for a moment. That was… Priorities, she reminded herself. "Did Alpha suggest that?" It would fit the artificial intelligence.

"Yes." Entrapta nodded. "She argued that with Adora there, they could get data on how the Jaffa would react to various agents without significant risks of an outbreak."

Of course, Alpha would! Sam pressed her lips together. "Did Loki support this?"

"Well… he didn't say so, but he had a lot of questions about which agents should be used. And he didn't press us to go straight to researching the cure for his species, so… yes? Maybe?"

Definitely, Sam mentally corrected her friend. Well, as long as none went along with Alpha's suggestions… "So, the synthetic symbiont does fully replace the Prim'ta."

"Yes! The Jaffa won't need to use Goa'uld children for their immune systems any more!"

That was a very Entrapta take on the way the Goa'uld ensured loyalty from their Jaffa. Or a very Etherian one. "I see."

"So, we've started production on the symbionts. And now that we know it works on Jaffa, we can start testing them on humans."

Sam suppressed a wince. She knew that this would be coming. Morrison had talked about it several times during the research. Goa'uld enhanced the immune system of their hosts - among other improvements. A synthetic symbiont that replaced the immune system of a Jaffa might also enhance a human's immune system. They had focused on replacing the Prim'tas, but with that problem solved, the next step was obvious.

And it was also almost certain that they would succeed. Jaffa were an off-shot of humans, genetically altered to serve the Goa'uld as warriors. But they weren't too far removed - it was questionable if

they were a different species or a subspecies. And the Goa'uld themselves were able to adapt to a wide range of hosts.

And that raised a lot of rather difficult ethical questions. "Before we start human testing, I think we need to discuss this with our friends."

"Right. Adora said so as well. Kinda." Entrapta nodded. "We have to be sure it won't harm people."

That was only part of the problem. "There's also the question about the consequences of such symbionts working on humans," Sam said.

"Huh?"

"Enhancing humans is a delicate issue." And that was putting it mildly.

"Why? It's a straight improvement! If the synthetic symbiont can be adapted - and that should be easy according to our projections - then it will make people much healthier! It can defeat most diseases without any magical healing needed. Or any medical treatment. People won't get sick in the first place and with a symbiont, they will heal up much faster after accidents," Entrapta said. "Your healthcare system will be able to save a ton of money!"

Which meant a lot of people would be out of work as well. On the other hand, they would need every doctor and nurse they could get for the war. "The thought of implanting a symbiont into your body might not appeal to everyone." Sam shuddered at the thought herself, remembering Jolinar.

"But why? It's so beneficial! And much cheaper than most of your medical procedures - we checked!" Entrapta shook her head. "That makes no sense."

"People aren't always logical," Sam told her friend. Not even Sam herself.

“Well, they don’t have to get a symbiont, then. Although, that means they will require more expensive treatment when they get sick or have an accident. Or they get wounded in the war. That’s not really fair either, is it?”

Sam slowly nodded. It wasn’t fair. But neither was forcing people to get a symbiont. And she knew the pressure to get one would be great. Especially in the United States with its sham of a public healthcare system. But many people wouldn’t want an alien symbiont. Certainly not one based on the Goa’uld.

And almost every medical corporation would fight against this. Not because of the ethical questions, of course, but because most of their research would be obsolete if symbionts were widely accepted and available. They had already made rumblings about magical healing before they had realised that healers required extensive training - more than doctors - to be effective. This would be magnitudes worse and threaten to bankrupt them all. They would fight this tooth and nail. Even though such symbionts would be able to save many people modern medicine couldn’t save. So, desperate people would fight to get such symbionts, especially if why couldn’t get magical healing.

And as the Alliance’s chief scientific officer who had been involved with this research practically from the start, Sam would be in the middle of this mess.

She almost wished for a crisis to give her an excuse to avoid this.

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The Symbionts Part 1

Bright Moon, Etheria, October 28th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and that's it. The synthetic symbiont should be a straight enhancement to people's immune systems. Once we have tested it, of course - but we have designed it, and we don't expect too many problems. It will be a great boon to healthcare, both on Etheria and on Earth, I think!"

Catra suppressed a wince at Entrapta's enthusiastic presentation. Adora had told her about this, so she wasn't surprised.

Unlike some of the others in the meeting room.

"You want to put those snakes into us?" Spinnerella looked shocked..

"Well, yes?" Entrapta cocked her head. "They're perfectly safe. Or will be when we finish testing them. We don't know yet if we need to make some adjustments and modifications."

"You made artificial Goa'uld?" Frosta asked with wide eyes.

"Not really? Well, we used Goa'uld DNA as a base - we had to, well, we could have chosen not to, but since the Jaffa were altered to require Goa'uld larvae for their immune system once they reach puberty, replacing the Prim'ta was far quicker and easier than trying to reverse the genetic alterations done to the Jaffa. Which would actually be a better solution, removing the need for a symbiont altogether, but I was told that this would also kinda change their species, so we shouldn't do that until they ask for it. It's still the obvious solution, so I think they'll see that. Anyway, we could have used something else as a base, but that would have been just extra steps we'd have to do. It's not as if we altered a Goa'uld, anyway - we just took key gene sequences from them and added them to the DNA of an artificially created species. That way, we didn't experiment on people!" Entrapta beamed.

Unfortunately, the rest of the princesses didn't seem to appreciate her reasoning.

"It's…" Spinnerella shook her head. "I don't want a snake inside me. Synthetic or not." Netossa held her hand, Catra saw.

"I don't want one inside me, either," Mermista said with a scowl.

"But why not? You'd never be sick again. Well, not unless you were targeted with a biological weapon, and even in that case, your odds of surviving it would be much better with a symbiont," Entrapta replied.

"We have healers for that," Mermista shot back.

"But they can't cover everyone," Entrapta pointed out. "Not even Adora can heal everyone."

Catra nodded. Though the idiot certainly would try if she let her.

"But this symbiont can be grown in large numbers - we have to, since there are millions, probably billions of Jaffa who need one - and then distributed, saving countless people!" Entrapta beamed at the others.

"Good for them. I'll stick with a healer," Frosta said.

Entrapta frowned and tilted her head to the side. "That sounds a bit selfish, I think."

"So? Better be a bit selfish than have a snake wrapped around your spine." Frosta snorted.

"It would actually sit next to - or in - your liver," Entrapta said. "At least in humans, since they don't have a pouch for the Prim'ta. It would also work at the spine, but it's easier to implant it in the liver, and it has an easier time dealing with blood-based illnesses."

"And it's safe?" Scorpia asked.

“We won’t distribute it until we’re completely sure it’s perfectly safe!” Entrapta smiled at her.

Scorpia glanced at Perfuma. The princess slowly nodded. “Well, many creatures live in a symbiotic relationship with others. Plants and animals alike.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “All of us have symbiotic organisms in our bodies.”

“What?” Frosta blurted out. She wasn’t the only one looking a bit queasy, Catra noted.

“Yes. Our gut microbiota. Or gut flora,” Entrapta explained. “Bacteria, archaea, fungi and viruses that live in the digestive tract of our bodies. We have tons of them! It’s perfectly natural.”

“There’s nothing natural about an artificial snake in our guts!” Mermista snapped.

“It does sound rather… artificial,” Micah added with a wince.

“It’s a synthetic life form,” Entrapta told him. “But that’s not really different from us - we were artificially created as well. Most of us, at least. Though, technically, our ancestors were artificially created and then reproduced naturally. Still, the origin is the same.”

“That’s… not the point,” Glimmer, who had been oddly silent until now, said. “The idea of, ah, inserting a symbiont into your body is not as easy to accept as you think it is.”

“But why? It has so many benefits and no drawbacks! There’s absolutely no reason not to get a symbiont - once we have adapted and tested it, of course!” Entrapta said. “You’ll live longer and better, too.”

“What?” Catra hadn’t heard about that.

“It prolongs your life?”

"Well, since you're not going to be sick any more, you'll have much fewer health issues," Entrapta explained. "But since a Goa'uld host lives much longer than their average species, we expect that the symbiont will have a similar, though probably lesser, effect. Although we're optimistic that we can duplicate the full effect with a bit of work. Jaffa also live longer than humans, despite being so similar to their parent species, so that's another data point in favour of that theory."

Catra looked around in the sudden silence.

"I still don't want a snake inside me," Frosta muttered with a scowl.

But the others were rethinking the whole thing. Catra could tell.

It was one thing not to get sick anymore. With Adora around, none of them would have to worry about that. But to live longer? Maybe double your average lifespan?

This changed things.

And she couldn't help but wonder how this would be received on Earth.

They would have to be careful when telling the others the news.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, October 29th, 1999

"Los! Los! Das geht schneller! Los! Gleich kracht es hier!"

Jack O'Neill glanced at a platoon of German infantry rushing into a mock-up of a landing shuttle as he walked towards his office. Their training instructor was screaming himself hoarse as the soldiers simulated an emergency embarking.

"Meier! Sie sind auf eine Mine getreten! Ihr Bein ist weg und sie bluten!"

One of the soldiers stopped and dropped to the ground, screaming and holding his perfectly fine leg as he simulated an injury as ordered. Quite convincingly, even.

That soldier has a future in acting, Jack thought as two others grabbed the man and dragged him inside the mock-up, with a third grabbing the soldier's rifle. An HK G36, Jack noted, remembering the short-lived campaign by various corporations and politicians to standardise the small arms of the Alliance. It had been quietly buried by the treasuries when someone had run the numbers for replacing every existing assault rifle in NATO's arsenal. They were already spending enough to get everyone armour-piercing ammunition - which was standardised.

He grinned as he walked past the mock-up. Last he heard, Colt, Heckler&Koch etc. were now lobbying the Etherians, trying to sell them their rifles. Better them than I, he thought.

Alliance Special Operations Command had more leeway, anyway - they could pretty much use what small arms they wanted. Especially with so many different countries to pick gear from. Jack was still partial to the M4 carbine, but if one of his soldiers wanted to lug around a G3 or FAL, that was no skin of his butt. They just couldn't complain about the weight, of course. It wasn't as if he could order them to use standardised weapons, not with some of the Etherian soldiers in his command carrying bows and arrows! Granted, they were mostly shooting trick and magic arrows, but Jack still made sure they were trained on firearms as well.

To think they had fought tanks and spaceships with that! Jack could only hope the rest of his soldiers didn't get any weird ideas. Bow - or Glimmer - had been clear that they couldn't supply everyone with such arrows.

Jack nodded at the two guards at the gate to his own little corner of the main Alliance base on Earth. "Campbell. Isa."

Both saluted - one in the British style, the other in Etherian - Scorpion Kingdom - style. Some of Jack's old drill instructors would have coronaries seeing that. Well, most of them would have lost their temper seeing women in combat, much less special forces. At least until they'd have seen Isa carrying a heavy blaster - like an M2 machine gun - as her personal weapon. Or picking up a Humvee and carrying it into a landing shuttle.

Finding a uniform in her size had been nigh impossible, of course, but the quartermaster had managed after Jack had insisted. Everyone wearing the same uniform was important - it was difficult enough to mould all those different people into a unit. They still weren't quite there yet, Jack knew. That would only happen once they had fought together. But they were as ready as they could be.

He entered his office. "Morning, Brown."

"Good morning, sir!" His aide looked up, nodded briefly, and went back to sorting through reports and other paperwork.

Jack had an aide now. That took some getting used to. "Anything urgent?" he asked as he grabbed his mail.

"No, sir." Brown paused. "Another request for the stealth shuttle from General Naird, sir."

Jack groaned.

"I've sent him the usual reply, sir."

"Good!" Some day, Naird would have to accept that it was Jack's *personal* shuttle. Personally gifted to him by Her Royal Highness Princess Entrapta of Dryl. Technically, it was on loan to the Alliance by Jack.

Naird knew that but still tried his 'the Air Force is in command of all space-going vessels stationed on a planet' routine. The man was just jealous that Jack had a personal stealth shuttle, and he didn't even have a normal shuttle and had to make do with

borrowing one from the Air Force's roster when he wanted to take a trip.

He nodded at Brown again and stepped into his office. The coffee maker - which made perfectly fine coffee no matter what Daniel claimed - was already running. Brown knew Jack's routine by now. He was no Carter - or Daniel - but he'd do as an aide.

Jack filled a cup and switched his computer on. While the machine started up, he took a sip and used the remote to quickly check CNN on the TV in the corner. As a general, he had to stay informed, after all. And no one could tell him off, anyway.

"...and the United Nations Commission on Human Rights was, once again, harshly criticised by several member states for its allegedly - I quote - 'blatant bias against any country that isn't under control by aliens'. These accusations follow in the wake of the commission's latest report about human rights violations in China's western provinces. China's government has refuted the report in its entirety, claiming it was a fabrication for political gains, and announced that it would veto any motion based on the report. This despite the commission's report also claiming that China had taken steps to improve its prisons and judicial systems, allegedly in response to the Etherian Intervention in Iran. The Chinese government didn't comment on the situation in North Korea, and…"

Jack finished his coffee and sighed. Nothing new on that front. He hoped it stayed that way. If North Korea destabilised, things would get messy. And Taiwan's attempts to get into the Alliance weren't helping either. Explaining that mess to the Etherians must have driven a few members of the state department into early retirement.

Well, neither was his problem. His problem was getting his troops ready for the coming offensive. No matter what planet they would strike, Jack was sure that his soldiers would be the first to fight.

Or at least the second, right after the princesses.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, October 30th, 1999

"...and so, to make asteroid mining cost-effective would require more dedicated spacecraft, mainly for transport, and trained personnel and special gear to do the actual extraction. Even so, it would only be competitive for rare earths unless and until orbital infrastructure to handle large-scale mining is being built, coupled with transportation that can ferry entire asteroids to said infrastructure." The scientist doing the presentation - Dr Wallander - nodded as he finished his exposition.

Before Adora could even thank the man, the American Secretary of Defense spoke up: "Pushing entire asteroids towards Earth? One mistake, and we're done for!"

Wallander shook his head. "The orbital guard flotilla can handle even a large asteroid. With the distances involved, any failure to decelerate that would put Earth at risk would be obvious long before it gets close to Earth. In extremis, a single frigate can break up any asteroid into pieces small enough to burn up on atmospheric entry."

"Do you know how many voters will think of Armageddon when they hear 'asteroids flying towards Earth'?"

Wallander frowned. "Do you mean the movie? That was very inaccurate, from a scientific point of view, and…"

"Scientific accuracy doesn't mean anything to the voters!" the American snapped.

"And that's your problem," Catra muttered next to Adora.

Adora cleared her throat. "We're not here to discuss American elections." They were more than a year away, anyway. "We're here to discuss how to ensure that the Alliance will continue to be

supplied with the raw materials we need for our military production. Asteroid mining is a possible solution."

"We can cover the needs with existing production on Earth," the German Verteidigungsminister cut in.

"So far," his British counterpart retorted. "As we ramp up production, we'll run into shortages."

"And mining puts a terrible burden on nature," Perfuma cut in. "It threatens to contaminate your supply of food and water."

That was exaggerated, as far as Adora knew. At least in Europe. But it was a concern that couldn't be ignored.

"And we have to consider the future - no ore deposit will last forever, and creating an entire fleet of spaceships takes a lot of resources." The British Minister nodded.

"And using space mining will see some return of investment for our space infrastructure," the French Minister added.

"Making our orbital defence stations dual-use will mean they're still legitimate military targets," the German objected.

"The Goa'uld don't care about your laws of war." Catra rolled her eyes. "Besides, we already have asteroid mining facilities for the spy bot network."

"Not in the Solar System," Dr Wallander said. "And automated systems are not flexible enough to mine efficiently as demand changes. They work for your automated drone production facilities, but that's not an option for us here."

It wouldn't be diplomatic to mention that they had moved the spy bot factories to nearby systems to avoid complaints about 'stealing the Solar System's resources' and 'exploitation in the tradition of colonialism' from the United Nations. Even though they were doing this to protect Earth. So Adora nodded. "Make a study about the projected costs for either solution and how long it

would take to implement either." They could decide which variant to implement, if any, when they had that information. "And since we're talking about space infrastructure, what's the status of the fleet transports?" She looked at Catra.

Her lover rolled her eyes again; they had gone over this before the meeting, but appearances and forms had to be kept, like at a Princess Prom. "They're on schedule. And the first block should be entering service in a few weeks, depending on how their shakedown cruises go. In an emergency, we could already call upon them."

"They're ahead of our own projects," the Norwegian Minister commented.

The American Secretary of Defense bristled at that. "You can't compare transports being built in automated factories using existing designs with creating an entire industry to build warships from scratch!"

It would be very undiplomatic to mention that just using Horde frigates would have worked as well - that was what the Princess Alliance was doing, after all. Etheria's Home Fleet - or Fourth Fleet, depending on who you asked - was using frigates built by Second Fleet's supply train but crewed by Etherians who were being trained by clones. Not even Salineas's shipyards were switching to spaceships any time soon. As Mermista had put it, she'd rather do that after the war when it could be done right, and with thousands of Salinean sailors with experience in space to help, than rush it with 'half-baked designs and untrained workers'.

But Earth didn't do things like that. They wanted to build their own ships. Which was fine but would take longer. And complicate the supply issues for the Alliance, of course. At least they would soon have the transport and supply capacity for multiple ground divisions - pretty much the entire expeditionary force that was, at least nominally, ready for operations right now.

And, speaking of soldiers… Adora cleared her throat again. "There's another issue we need to discuss. We have had a breakthrough in our research to produce synthetic symbionts. As soon as we have sufficient production, we can supply replacement symbionts to all our Jaffa prisoners and then extend that to other Jaffa."

"Let's hope we'll get enough defectors to join our side," the Secretary of Defence muttered. "We've spent enough on that project."

Mostly Etheria, actually, Adora knew that. And it wasn't as if they had paid actual money for using Research Station Alpha. But every day Entrapta, Hordak and the others were working there, they weren't working on other projects, and that was an opportunity cost which had to be accounted for - at least according to the Alliance budget commission.

She took a deep breath before continuing. "There's an additional benefit from the research," she said. "According to our preliminary research, the synthetic symbionts would be able to provide substantial benefits to humans as well, namely, greatly enhancing their immune system and, potentially, significantly prolonging their lifespans."

For a moment, the meeting room was dead silent. Then everyone seemed to speak up at once.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, October 31st, 1999

"I am a physicist, sir. Not a geneticist," Samantha Carter repeated herself for what felt like the tenth time today. Why did people think she was an expert on everything? Granted, she had dealt with a wide range of scientific challenges at Stargate Command, but usually in emergencies.

“Major Carter, please don’t play coy. You were involved in the entire project from the start - from before the start. We need your assessment of this recent development.” The Secretary of Defense leaned forward, putting both elbows on the table in the small meeting room.

Sam could clearly hear the emphasis on ‘recent’ the man used. “I was focused on security, administrative and technical tasks.” That was technically true. “Dr Morrison was a lead researcher. I am sure his report covers whatever you need to know.”

“Dr Morrison’s report covers biological issues. What we need are hard numbers about production. How quickly can those synthetic things be manufactured? And at what cost? You built those robot factories with Princess Entrapta.”

Sam pressed her lips together for a moment. “The synthetic symbionts are organic lifeforms, sir. They need to be grown in cloning tanks. They can’t be built on assembly lines by automated systems.” It was a bit more complicated than that, with bioreactors needed for various products to feed the cloning tanks, and automation was certainly an important part, but she doubted the man would understand the process.

The man made a dismissive gesture with his hand. “Yes, yes, I know that. What I - what we, the government - don’t know yet is: How much does it cost to build enough of those things to supply the American population, and how long will it take?”

Sam raised her eyebrows. “The *American* population?”

“They’re our responsibility. We swore an oath, Major.” The Secretary narrowed his eyes.

“Production facilities are already being set up on Etheria.” She knew better than to respond to the implied rebuke.

“For the symbionts for the Jaffa. Not the symbionts for humans. Those are still being researched, aren’t they?” The man looked at her as if he suddenly suspected a cover-up.

“They are being tested, yes,” she said. “We don’t know yet if the design will have to be altered. Potential long-term effects have to be thoroughly examined.”

“People are already asking why months of research - almost a year - were spent on ways to benefit our enemies instead of us.”

What? By ‘people’ he must mean his colleagues. The symbionts were classified. And those with the clearance would know better than to ask such questions! She met the man’s eyes with a glare of her own. “The project was ordered by Alliance Command, in accordance with our general strategy against the Goa’uld.” They needed those symbionts to turn the Jaffa. And to keep prisoners alive.

“I know that. But people wonder if we should have changed our goals once the potential of the symbionts became obvious.”

“The research team focused on the task they were given,” Sam replied to the unspoken accusation. “And on the other crucial genetic research. The potential applications for humans were only discovered once the project had entered the final testing phase.”

The Secretary of Defense snorted at that but didn’t push the issue. Though Sam was sure he wouldn’t show such restraint if she wasn’t friends with Entrapta and the other princesses. “We need those projections. This is one of the most important issues for our government - for the world. If this leaks - when this leaks - to the public, there will be riots in the streets and worse if we don’t have answers and a plan. Hell, there’ll be riots anyway.”

Sam was aware of that, of course. Some people would be horrified at the idea. And some would suspect everyone who got a symbiont as a potential traitor. Or someone who had sold their soul. But many would be clamouring for a symbiont. “We’re still building the production facilities for the symbionts meant for the Jaffa. Once they are up and running, we have a baseline and can project numbers for the variant for humans and Etherians. But we were planning to produce a million symbionts in the first year, and

scaling up those numbers by two or three magnitudes, which would be needed just to cover the potential short-term demand in the Alliance, is a challenge." To say the least. The effort to produce a million Jaffa-symbionts was already straining the resources of Etheria, and that was with Perfuma delivering any organic base materials for basically free.

"The alternative is civil unrest of a scale we can't imagine. And the complete collapse of the healthcare industry. All that in the middle of a war in space." He leaned forward even more. "We need those numbers, Major! We need to know what it will cost, and how long it'll take, so we know what we can do to deal with this."

Sam had some doubts about the man's priorities, but he wasn't wrong. "I'll get on it, sir." That would delay other projects, but she wasn't looking forward to more troubleshooting for the Constellation-II project anyway. "We should…"

The Secretary of Defense's mobile phone went off, interrupting her. He took the call, turning away from her.

"Yes?"

"I'm in the middle of… What?" He paused. "WHAT?"

His head whipped around, and he stared at Sam again. "Someone leaked it to the media! CNN is going to run a report on this!"

Sam felt her stomach drop. That wasn't good. Not at all.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, October 31st, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and we're waiting for the United States Government to comment on the claim that Alliance scientists have found a way to extend the human lifespan by at least a hundred years, in perfect health, by using alien technology. A press conference has been

announced but has been delayed for 'technical reasons', so speculation is running rampant."

"Thank you, Bob. Now, this was leaked by an anonymous source. Can this information be trusted? It sounds fantastical - almost too good to be true. We've got an expert on the matter here. Professor Smith, as one of the foremost experts in this particular field, what do you think?"

"Well, thank you for having me here. Some time ago, I would have said this sounded too good to be true due to my research into anti-ageing treatments. However, this was before we met the Etherians and, most importantly, before the return of magic. Nowadays, after analysing the various people who were healed by Princess She-Ra, the consensus amongst my colleagues is that, with magical means, curing any disability is possible, which should result in extending human lifespan by several decades at the least."

"That's short of the hundred years we were told was the baseline, Professor."

"Exactly. And that's peculiar, isn't it? I would have expected a more conservative number. Now, this might just be a bit of hyperbole, or it might be indicative of more than merely healing ailments. We have not even begun to delve into what magical healing can do, but we know that at least some individuals lived for centuries on Etheria."

"That would be a very long time indeed."

"Yes. However, we don't know yet what it takes to achieve that. Magical talent is not common, as we know by now, and such treatments might be beyond the power of the vast majority of sorceresses, even Etherian ones."

"You mean, only She-Ra could do this, Professor?"

"That might be the case, yes."

Catra muttered a curse and muted the screen. “And here I was looking forward to Halloween.” Those bastards just had to ruin her and Adora’s day. The one day of the year she could have gone out without a disguise and be mistaken for someone wearing a catgirl - or Catra - costume with Adora, and those idiots had to ruin it!

“We can still go to the party at Alliance Headquarters,” Bow said. “Although we probably have to talk about this with the Council first.”

Catra scoffed. “Talk to the same people who leaked this? So they can leak more information?”

“We don’t know who leaked it,” Bow retorted.

“So we have to find the leak first.” That would be difficult, with so many suspects. They had informed all the governments in the Alliance, after all. And those would have discussed it internally, looked for more angles and information… “We need to revamp how we handle such information,” she said.

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “We can’t fight a war if everything gets leaked. We cannot count on being secure from infiltrators forever - certainly not once we start occupying more planets.”

“And we need to tell everyone about the symbionts,” Adora spoke up. Catra saw that she had raised her chin slightly - she wouldn’t budge on that. “We can’t have people think I can make them immortal!”

Catra nodded. They would hound her forever. People were already speculating about eternal youth.

“The Council won’t like it,” Glimmer said. “But that’s their problem. We won’t lie for them if they can’t control their media.”

More like wouldn’t control them, Catra thought. “So… let’s meet the press?”

“We need to inform our allies first,” Glimmer said.

"Yes," Bow agreed.

Catra snorted. "We could probably skip the press release then - someone will leak it again."

Glimmer chuckled, but Adora and Bow didn't seem to think it was funny.

"We won't," Adora said. "We'll do this properly and tell people the truth."

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, October 31st, 1999

"...and we're working on adapting those symbionts to humans and other life forms. Based on the effects on Jaffa, which we tested, we expect a significant boost to the immune system, which should render a host mostly immune to most diseases and enhance their regeneration after suffering an injury. The effects on the lifespan beyond that are not yet clear but might be similar to the effects on the hosts of Goa'uld."

Catra saw Adora smile at the various reporters staring at her in the room.

"It's not magic. And you don't need a sorceress to use it. Any surgeon should be able to implant the symbiont easily and safely. But, as I said, we're still working on adapting the symbiont, so it'll take a while until it's available. We will ensure that it is perfectly safe, and that requires a lot of testing. Any questions?"

Catra's ears twitched, and she winced as the murmuring that had started during the news conference quickly grew painfully loud, some of the reporters jumping up from their seats and waving microphones, recorders and notepads around as they tried to shout over each other.

"When will this be available?"

“How long has this been in the pipeline?”

“How can you tell if this is safe?”

“Are you using Goa’uld for this?”

“Wo will receive those symbionts first?”

Yeah, this was going about as well as she had expected.

*****

Jack O’Neill took another sip from his glass and frowned. This Halloween party sucked. And not because they were in Europe, where Halloween wasn’t a thing. No, everyone here was either talking about the symbionts or watching the news about the symbionts. And a lot of people were too busy to attend in the first place.

Including Carter, who had apparently been ordered to prepare a briefing about the symbionts for the government. And Daniel, who was busy working on a paper about the consequences for society if people suddenly had a lifespan twice as long as before or something. He hadn’t even been ordered to do it - no, Jack’s friend had *volunteered* because he thought this couldn’t wait.

Jack had tried to get them to attend the party anyway, but both had turned them down. And he couldn’t exactly order them to attend since they - technically - weren’t in his chain of command any more. Well, they would be temporarily assigned to Special Operations Command for any operations, but they were not officially part of Jack’s command.

And no, Jack wasn’t thinking about what that might mean for certain regulations. Absolutely not.

“The differences between this event and last year’s Halloween party at Stargate Command are subtle but distinct, I believe.”

Well, at least one of Jack's friends had made the party. "What do you mean, Teal'c?" Jack asked as he turned.

"The selection of the dishes is more varied," Teal'c said, holding a plate loaded with finger food. "Healthier as well, I think. At least some of the fare," he added, eyeing his plate.

"That's because this is the Alliance Headquarters, not a base." Jack snorted. "The soldiers here are mostly paper pushers, so if they ate like soldiers in the field, they'd grow too fat to walk in no time."

Teal'c tilted his head to the side and raised an eyebrow. "I was told it is the result of so many soldiers from countries with vastly different culinary traditions working together."

Jack snorted again. "Well, that's the official explanation. Of course, they wouldn't admit that they are skipping P.T."

Teal'c's eyebrow remained where it was - he wasn't buying it. Well, can't win them all. Jack grinned. "But the variety is nice. As long as you stay away from the various Nordic dishes." The catering had included some truly *nasty* examples.

"I have yet to discover an inedible meal," Teal'c said. "Most were pleasantly spicy."

"Right." Jack shrugged. "And, speaking of stomachs… Are you going to get a replacement for Junior?"

Teal'c calmly finished a small pastry - something French, or maybe Belgian, Jack thought - before replying: "My Prim'ta has a few years left before it matures. I would not wish to deprive others who might need the synthetic symbionts more urgently of them merely for my convenience."

"Well, we don't exactly have an army of Jaffa lining up for a new baby snake," Jack said. "I am sure we can spare one for you." And get rid of the Goa'uld in his friend's belly before it matured and killing it became… morally dubious. And probably illegal.

"I believe that this might change once news of those synthetic symbionts spreads to those Jaffa who are currently trapped serving the false gods since becoming Shol'va would doom them to die."

"Yeah, 'freedom or death' sounds a lot better than 'freedom and death'," Jack said. Should he mention Teal'c's family? That was kind of a sore spot.

"Master Bra'tac should know more Jaffa who would be willing to defect now that their circumstances are bound to change."

Jack narrowed his eyes. That was a not-so-subtle - for Teal'c - request to contact his friend's old mentor. "I guess we should go and contact him, then." Now that they actually had those synthetic symbionts as an incentive, that should outweigh the concerns about secrecy that the Alliance brass kept bringing up to block such a mission.

"Indeed."

"Well, let's see where our Supreme Commander is currently hiding," Jack said, looking around. "Did you see her anywhere?" Adora and her friends were attending the party, after their original plans had fallen through thanks to CNN, but they might have decided to risk going out in public anyway - this party sucked, after all.

"Not after the first round of introductions," Teal'c replied. "However, I believe I know where they can be found."

Hm? What was Teal'c looking at? Jack turned his head. The buffet? Yes. And the right wing of the buffet, where the seafood was. Ah! He grinned. "Yeah, let's check our bait. If our furry friend is still around, she'll bite sooner or later." And since Catra wouldn't leave Adora's side for any length of time if she could help it, if they found Catra, they'd find Adora as well.

*****

The Alliance Headquarters Halloween party is disappointing, Adora thought. She had expected a party more like the New Year's Eve Party at Stargate Command, where everyone had a good time. Sure, there had been a few incidents, but nothing really serious, and people had fun even though there was some 'networking', or what you called it. Here, though, it felt more like Princess Prom, just without the fun parts. Everyone seemed to be working on something, trying to gather support for this and that - and as the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, everyone wanted to talk to her.

That the news about the synthetic symbionts had been revealed today didn't help, of course. On the contrary.

All in all, this wasn't a fun costume party, like in the TV shows, but just another work meeting, just with drinks and better food. And Adora already had had all the meetings and work she could stand today.

Not that hiding in a side room - marked 'defunct - keep out' thanks to Catra doing something to the maintenance records that Adora didn't want to know more about - was fun, either. But it was a room with a view of Brussels, and at night, and from afar, the city looked very pretty.

"So, you're really going to stay here?"

Adora turned to smile, if a bit tiredly, at Glimmer. "I don't think it's a good idea for Catra and me to go out today."

"You'd be in disguise - in costume," Glimmer said. "Like us." She had changed into a 'Batgirl' costume herself, though she had left the cowl with the red wig off for now. Bow was going as 'Robin'. "We still have the Wonder Woman and Cheetah costumes…"

Adora frowned at her friend. "We're not going to dye Catra's fur." Really! Catra would claw them!

Glimmer grinned a bit sheepishly. "It would wash out. And it would be the perfect disguise for her!"

“Too perfect,” Adora retorted. People would quickly realise that the fur wasn’t a costume.

“Still better than her plans.” Glimmer snorted. “Going as herself? Please!”

“Refuge in audacity?” Adora offered with a weak smile. It wasn’t a good plan, in her opinion, but it might have worked well enough as long as Catra wore a suit covering most of her fur. But not now that the symbiont news had spread and everyone was focused on them. And on Adora specifically. At least there were no riots in Brussels. So far.

The door opened - that would be Catra, returning from her third ‘food run’. Or ‘fishing expedition’. Adora turned, then blinked.

“So, this is where you were hiding.” Jack looked around as Teal’c closed the door behind them.

“They were waiting at the buffet,” Catra said, scowling as she put a large plate of food on the table.

“And you walked into their ambush?” Glimmer shook her head with a sigh. “You’re slipping.”

“I didn’t think they would insist on following me,” Catra retorted. “I guess I could have tried to lose them…”

“No!” Adora snapped. “So, are you also hiding?” she asked, grabbing a small sandwich from the plate. Not a salmon one, of course - everyone knew better than trying to get between Catra and those.

“Not exactly.” Jack smiled. He was up to something, Adora realised. “But something came up, and we wanted to talk to you about it.”

Catra groaned through a mouth stuffed with a Nordic fish dish.

“And it couldn’t have waited until tomorrow?” Glimmer asked, narrowing her eyes.

Jack’s smile grew a bit wider. “It probably could, but the party sucks, and it doesn’t look as if you’ve got anything better to do if you’re hiding in here…”

He wasn’t entirely wrong - at least as far as Adora was concerned.

Catra, though, snorted. “Wait until we tell Daniel and Sam that you’d rather work than party. And we had plans - we were going to break in the table as soon as Glimmer and Bow left.”

Adora gasped at her - fortunately, she hadn’t been drinking at the moment. “Catra!”

“What? It’s true.”

“That’s…” Adora pressed her lips together as she felt her cheeks heat up. She raised her chin and turned to Jack and Teal’c. “So, what do you want to talk about?” she asked as professionally as she could.

“Ah, it’s about Teal’c’s family and friends amongst the Jaffa,” Jack said. “Now that we have replacements for the baby snakes, we should revisit them.”

“The circumstances regarding them have changed, I believe,” Teal’c added.

Adora nodded at once. “Of course!” As if they’d keep their friend from his family and friends if he wanted to see them!

*****

The Symbionts Part 2

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 1st, 1999

The screen showed a dark sky with a lot of stars. Judging from the relative lack of light pollution, the camera was in the countryside, not in a city. Samantha Carter knew that already from the file, but confirmation was always good.

The quality wasn't the best - it was a little grainy. Not a high-end camera. Something else that she knew already. But it was better than most security cameras. She could see glowing lights in the sky as the camera turned around and focused on them.

"Oh! What's that?"

"Fireworks! Pretty!"

"Fireworks? Out here?"

"Those aren't fireworks!"

"They're coming closer!"

"Planes?"

"Shuttles! Must be alien shuttles!

"Oh! Aliens, here?"

The sound quality was… not very good either. But the excited voices of a family of four - as shown in the earlier parts of the recording - were clearly audible.

"Those are… Dear Lord!"

The camera shook as the lights grew larger, more defined - and then spectral forms flew above it, low enough so the camera could

pick up barking over the screams from the family, shortly before the camera showed the ground, then trees, as the man holding it must have ducked. He would have been too late to avoid the flying objects, Sam knew, if they had been coming for him.

But they hadn't come for him. The camera swung back and forth until it caught the back of the spectral forms flying through the sky. Wolves or dogs, Sam noted. *Hounds*, she added a moment later. A dozen of them. *Exactly* a dozen.

"What were they, Dad?"

"I don't know, dear."

"Flying dogs? Like Swift Wind?"

"I don't think so, dear."

No, not like Swift Wind. Sam shook her head as she stopped the recording on her screen. She hadn't noticed anything new this time. Nothing useful.

She opened the stills taken from the recording. The best showed a large wolf or dog's form, lined in glowing red-orange colours, racing through the sky, its legs moving as if it were running over a field.

"That's not an Etherian creature," Glimmer said behind her. "Not anyone I recognise, at least."

"It's not Swift Wind," Adora added.

"We already know that," Catra said. "Swift Wind has wings. And he doesn't glow like that."

"Well, he could if you used some glowing paint," Bow pointed out. He cocked his head. "Although the silhouettes are wrong.

"There aren't any wings, and the movements don't match those of winged flight," Sam said. She had run the recording through a few

simulations to compare the movements to those of Swift Wind during his appearance at Disney World a few months ago.

“Do we have recordings of the attack?” Glimmer asked.

“No. Just the reports from eyewitnesses,” Sam said. If they had such recordings, she would have shown them already.

“And those reports match these images?” Adora asked.

“Yes.” Sam nodded. “Red or orange glowing spectral dogs, attacking a small house in Wales and burning it down. The resident, Father Julian Gardner, was found dead in the remains by the fire brigade.”

“Ah.”

“Did he burn to death?” Catra asked.

“The autopsy hasn’t finished yet,” Sam said. “But the pictures we got…” A click of her mouse opened another series of pictures on the big screen.

“Ew!”

“That’s…”

“Looks like they tore out his throat. It reminds me of the remains of some of the scouting parties we lost in the Whispering Woods.”

“Catra!”

“What?”

“Preliminary examinations support this assumption,” Sam said. “The body was found in the middle of the living room, and the witnesses claim that he would have had enough time to escape through the door after the creatures left before the fire consumed the house.”

“See?”

“That’s not the point!”

“Anyway,” Glimmer spoke over Adora and Catra’s bickering, “Those weren’t Etherian creatures. I’ve never heard of anything like them.”

Sam nodded. She had deemed that unlikely in the first place - they had extensive security on both sides of the Stargate to prevent unauthorised access. A must, with magic, Goa’uld and shapeshifters present. The chance that such creatures had snuck through was very low.

But if they hadn’t travelled to Earth from Etheria, they would have had to come from another planet, which was equally unlikely. Or they had originated on Earth. Sam pressed her lips together. She would have preferred it if the creatures had come through the Stargate, despite what that would have said about their security.

“So, since it’s not from Etheria…” Catra trailed off.

Sam sighed as Daniel, who must have bitten his tongue to not speak up while their friends had watched the recording, eagerly nodded. “I’ve done a bit of research. I’m no expert, of course, but the date, the pictures, the location and the accounts of the witnesses all fit my conclusion.” He pushed a key on his laptop, and a set of pictures appeared on the screen to the side. A mix of illustrations and paintings of various styles, mostly medieval. “Yesterday was Halloween. A celebration based on the old Samhain, of Celtic origin - well, that’s a simplified version; the popular perception of what’s supposed to be ‘Celtic’ is slightly outdated, and nowadays, we have...”

Sam cleared her throat.

“Ah, sorry!” Daniel smiled a little sheepishly at her. “Anyway, Samhain was said to have mystic - or magical significance in folklore. And the pictures and descriptions we saw match the myth of the Cŵn Annwn, also called the Hell Hounds.” He pushed his glasses up. “It’s just a hypothesis for now, but I believe this is

an example of a major magic feat achieved by following Earth traditions. Magical traditions. I think someone successfully called up or summoned the Wild Hunt."

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 2nd, 1999

"...and reports from Ireland confirm similar incidents, although none of them fatal. In Dublin, several witnesses described 'a leprechaun prancing in the street'. Footage from security cameras seems to support those reports."

The picture of the news anchor was replaced by a grainy, black-and-white recording of a small, tiny creature with an oversized hat flitting past the pavement. Too small to be a human child.

Catra shook her head as the news anchorman reappeared.

"Authorities are still trying to determine if the Giant's Causeway has been altered, as some experts claim. What has been confirmed is that the Stone of Destiny on the Hill of Tara has been glowing since the night of Halloween - or Samhain. So far, neither the British nor Irish governments have commented on repeated requests for further information, though anonymous sources from both countries maintain that there is definite proof of several magical incidents, and we…"

Catra changed the channel.

"...and while the United Nations are debating how to deal with potentially lethal magic incidents, protestors are assembling in front of the Palais des Nations in Geneva, Switzerland, and the Headquarters of the United Nations in New York. The police are trying to separate those demanding harsh measures against practitioners of magic and those defending magic as part of their religion, but several clashes have already been observed, leading to at least two wounded people in New York. This comes on the heels of the tense protests for and against the so-called 'synthetic

symbiont' the Alliance High Command has developed, which are expected to fundamentally alter healthcare as we know it should they be approved for treatment, and…"

Catra changed the channel again. An overweight, angry man appeared, speaking into a microphone someone else was holding.

"Weren't we told that the magic on Earth would be safe? Weak? Harmless? And now, a good, God-fearing man - a priest tending to his flock! - was murdered by fell sorcery! Burned to death in his home! How many more people who will not bow to godless aliens will suffer his fate? How many more curses will be cast at other men of the cloth? How much longer until we will finally heed what the Bible tells us? Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live! That is God's will and…"

Catra rolled her eyes and muttered a cure as she changed the channel again.

"...and in light of the events on Halloween, one wonders if we should not rethink our stance towards the Middle-Eastern countries' controversial policies towards sorceresses. While a blanket criminalisation of all magic is clearly too much, harsh punishments for dangerous sorcery seem an adequate response to this new danger, and…"

Was everyone going crazy? Catra hissed. "So, that's their angle! One death - which hasn't even been confirmed yet as a magical murder - and they're asking for witch hunts."

"You know how Earth media work," Glimmer commented - though Catra could tell that she was angry as well. "They always do that when something happens. Our allies could really do with better control over their news services."

"Good luck with that." Catra snorted. Their allies had been very clear about 'freedom of the press'. She glanced at Sam and Daniel.

“Well, it’s a really delicate problem,” Daniel said. “Our past experiences have left a lasting impression - the ability to control the media can be horribly abused, and…”

“Yes, yes!” Catra made a dismissive gesture with her hand. “We know.”

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded. “So, since control over the media is out, what can you do about this?” She pointed at the screen, which had turned dark.

“About the magic issue? Or the symbionts?” Daniel asked.

“Both,” Glimmer told him.

“There is not much we can do about the symbionts,” Sam said. “We’re still working on actually adapting them to humans, and we can’t tell how long that will take - and how much longer building facilities for mass production will take.”

“It’s up to the various governments how to handle this,” Daniel added.

Catra snorted again. “You think we will let anyone monopolise the symbionts?”

“I wouldn’t presume to make such an assumption.” Daniel wasn’t very good at acting innocently.

“We’re not going to do that, but we also won’t get dragged into that mess,” Glimmer said. “Not if we can help it.” Her expression clearly showed that she was sure they could help it.

Catra agreed. The Alliance wouldn’t work out if single countries could hoard symbionts. Or keep their people from using them if they wanted to.

“Yes.” Sam nodded. “But despite the hysteria and hyperbole, the media raised a good question: How could anyone send the Wild Hunt after someone? Magic of that power is supposed to be too

difficult for a beginner. At least, according to what we have been told." 'By you' remained unsaid but clearly understood.

Catra looked at Glimmer. She was the expert here.

Her friend sighed. "Yes, and I stand by that. But we also said that we don't know how Earth's magic would express itself. It could be that this - sending out such creatures - is how this planet's magic works. You certainly have enough legends and myths about magical creatures helping and harming people."

Daniel leaned forward with an eager expression. "You mean that Earth's native magical traditions might be rooted in summoning and controlling - through various means - different, ah, spirits? Almost every culture has myths about otherworldly creatures and how to interact with them. Djinns, kami, angels, demons, spirits, ghosts and various other mythical creatures. But would those be created by whoever calls on them, or is the magic calling upon existing creatures?"

"That's a good question," Glimmer said. "We don't know - yet. Etheria doesn't really have such traditions."

Daniel looked even more excited about the research they would have to do.

Sam, though, looked concerned.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, November 3rd, 1999

Everyone has gone nuts, Jack O'Neill thought as he saw the new 'security measures' taken at the Base: Lookouts to spot magical attacks. "So much for listening to the experts…" he muttered as he stepped through the gate to his part of the base.

"It's supposed to be just until we get other means of detecting such threats, sir," Jones, standing guard - with binocs - said.

Jack stopped and turned to look at Jones. He was a Navy Puke, former SEAL, but other than that, he was a good soldier. "And if we spot a 'Wild Hunt' approaching, what do we do?" Jack asked.

"Alert the base, sir!"

"And then?"

Jones grinned. "Pray?"

Jack snorted. "I'm pretty sure the priest prayed. Didn't save him."

"Well, sir, if the rumours about him are true…" Jones trailed off with a shrug.

Jack suppressed a sigh. It hadn't taken the media long to dig up rumours about child abuse and cover-ups. Some people were already talking about 'divine vengeance' having been visited upon the man.

"We can pray to She-Ra for protection," the other guard, Kelly, spoke up. He had a perfectly straight expression - Jack couldn't tell if the man was serious or joking. And he was SAS, which meant his sense of humour was British, further complicating matters.

But Jack wasn't touching that landmine today. "We're actually getting Etherian sorceresses assigned to the base for our protection." Amongst them Castaspella, though she was coming for research into Earth's magical traditions, now that they seemed to be emerging.

"Really, sir?" Kelly perked up.

"The Alliance isn't going to leave our main base vulnerable to any witch with a grudge," Jack said.

"Why would witches attack us, sir?" Kelly asked.

“Who knows what someone summoning the Wild Hunt thinks?” Jack shrugged. “They might think we threaten their gods or the world or something.”

“You think they worship the snakes, sir?” Jones looked concerned now.

“I doubt that,” Jack replied. Although, truth to be told, he couldn’t be sure. Stranger things had happened. Not that he would tell his troops that. “Magic and snakes don’t mix.”

That seemed to reassure the two soldiers. Jack was about to turn around and continue towards his office when Kelly spoke up again, “Uh, sir… we’ve heard another rumour. A mite concerning.”

“Yes?” Jack tilted his head - he needed his coffee. It was too early for this.

“Some people claim that we’re going to get the snake symbionts, whether we want them or not,” Jones said.

Oh, for…! Jack had to nip that in the bud. “We don’t have any symbionts yet - they’re still working on the things,” he said. “And once we have them - we don’t know when that will be the case - no one will be forced to get one. It’ll be strictly volunteer-only. If we even get any in the first place. Last I heard, demand is going to be high in the civilian market.” And amongst the rich and powerful, of course.

Despite the concern the two soldiers had voiced, that didn’t seem to please them either. “If those things are safe, they could be very useful for us,” Kelly said. “Especially for missions behind the enemy lines, without the possibility of medevacs.”

Jones nodded. “And we wouldn’t have to worry about alien bugs.” He shuddered - probably remembering the ‘here’s why you don’t eat or drink anything on an alien planet without our permission’ lecture Dr Fraser had given Jack’s soldiers at his request.

"We're aware of that," Jack told them. "But we're not going to force anyone to put a symbiont into their body." Even if some idiots were thinking about it, according to Adora. As a 'cost-saving measure', even! If that spread to the civilians, if someone suggested that people on welfare would have to get a symbiont so they wouldn't generate more costs…

He pushed the thought away and nodded at the guards. "So, don't worry about that, OK? One way or the other, we won't let you down." Jack would make sure of that.

"We know, sir." Kelly smiled, as did Jones.

That's one of the best things about the Alliance, Jack thought as he resumed walking to his office. With the princesses fighting on the frontlines, the politicians wouldn't be able to screw the soldiers over.

It was a small consolation, though. Between the symbionts and the new magic threat, things were bound to be messy for a while. And there was only so much Jack could do about either. He had to trust that his friends had things in hand. More or less.

He had work to do. Soldiers to train. Officers to pick. And the mission to contact Teal'c's mentor and family to prepare. His friend was counting on him, and Jack wouldn't let him down either.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 4th, 1999

"...and this is Chulak, Teal'c's home planet. We've got spy bots covering the system since it belongs to Apophis, who is kind of one of our main enemies since he has already attacked Earth once. Twice if you count his visit through the Stargate."

Adora nodded at Entrapta's exposition and looked at the holoprojection slowly rotating behind her friend. It was a smaller

planet than Etheria or Earth. Shorter daylight cycles, as Entrapta had told them.

"...and that's the Capital, named City of Chulak." Entrapta's hair tendrils pointed at a spot on the planet's main continent. Another tendril pushed a few keys on the computer next to her, and the screen behind her changed to show aerial pictures of the city.

Built on a hill but without fortifications, Adora noted. At least no visible fortifications, though a ground attack would have to fight through narrow streets and dense buildings, where the Jaffa would have the advantage as long as they had civilians to hide behind so you couldn't shell or bomb their positions. With stealth shuttles, you could drop troops directly on the palace - the temple - but you'd still have to root out the warriors in the city…

"These are the last known locations of Teal'c's family and Bra'tac," Entrapta went on as her hair whirled, highlighting more spots on the planet. "However, aerial surveillance showed both locations as deserted - or abandoned. Unfortunately, our spy bots aren't built for atmospheric entry since their main task is to system and orbital reconnaissance, so we don't have any more detailed information."

Adora pressed her lips together. That didn't look good.

"If Apophis had captured Bra'tac, he would have announced that to show his strength," Teal'c said. "There would have been a public execution or similar demonstration of the false god's power."

"Yeah, that's his style," Jack commented.

"And your family?" Glimmer asked.

"I believe that, should Apophis intend to use them as leverage against me, he would have announced the fact that he has them so I would hear of them," Teal'c replied. "However, since they have denounced me, they should be safe from retaliation."

“Unless he wants to turn you into a spy,” Catra said, “and doesn’t want us to know that he’s holding your family as hostages.”

“He would have to be able to contact Teal’c covertly for that,” Jack retorted. “That’s not easy - we aren’t exactly on speaking terms with him, and we don’t frequent the same places. Well, when we do, we tend to blow them up,” he added with a grin.

“He could still attempt to use them against you,” Catra pointed out. “Or just keep them prisoner in case there’s an opportunity to use them.”

Teal’c inclined his head.

“Well, we’ll have to find out where they are,” Daniel said with obviously forced optimism. “We did it once already.”

“Apophis’s hold on Chulak is not as tight as on other planets,” Teal’c said. “He conquered it from Chronos, but he never invested too much in the world.”

Adora could see that on the screen. Chulak’s Stargate was standing in the open, without visible fortifications or guards.

“Chulak isn’t part of Apophis’s core worlds,” Sam said.

Adora nodded. The System Lords usually focused on a few worlds, developed and well-defended. And many of the remaining worlds under their control only had token Jaffa garrisons - sometimes not even that - and few settlements that provided raw materials or agricultural produce to the core worlds. And recruits for their armies and slaves for their factories, farms and mines.

“So… do we sneak through the Stargate, or do we fly there?” Daniel asked. “We’ve used the Stargate before, and it doesn’t look as if they changed anything.” He peered at the pictures on the screen.

“Or that’s what he wants us to think,” Catra muttered with a frown. “It’s the best spot for a trap. He has to have surveillance

on it, at least."

"The false gods often rely on their faithful to report to them," Teal'c said. "Or, rather, they used to - we cannot rely on them remaining so complacent. Not with the tensions between them running high."

"Yeah. Apophis is the kind of snake to pull something like that," Jack said. "But can he do that on every world?"

"Can we risk it?" Catra cocked her head to the side.

"He would still have to spot us to trigger what trap he might have laid." Jack grinned. "We've got a good record for sneaking through Stargates."

And a ship would take weeks to reach the world. They could send a flotilla, with Third Fleet's flagship, so they would be able to use the Stargate to travel there, but that was still a bit tricky - and too close to an invasion. And you didn't launch an invasion without more intel about the planet.

"So we try to sneak in?" Glimmer asked.

Jack nodded. "Yes. Like old times," he added with a grin.

Stargate Command had been running such missions, Adora knew. But they had also often been running into trouble on such trips. Still, it was feasible - and Jack had been training his command for such operations for months now. They needed some real experience.

She nodded. "Yes. But we'll use spy bots first. On the ground as well."

"Yes!" Entrapta beamed. "We can use our new stealth bots for that! The Goa'uld shouldn't be able to detect them!"

"But we'll need a cover for the gate activation. The gate opening without anyone coming through would look suspicious - and make

the Goa'uld suspect that we have such stealth assets," Sam added.

"I think between us and the Tok'ra, we can come up with a cover," Catra said. "They've been running such missions for a long time."

Adora nodded again. "Then it's settled."

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 5th, 1999

"Sam. Entrapta."

Anise wasn't happy. Samantha Carter would have been able to tell even if she hadn't received advance notice of her friend's visit in a rather clipped tone. Usually, the Tok'ra scientist was looking around curiously when she entered Sam's lab - or the spacelab - and generally was smiling when she greeted her friends.

Today, she was… 'not quite frowning' would fit it best, Sam decided. "Hello, Anise."

"Hi!" Entrapta, of course, was smiling widely. "How are you doing? How is your research into the portable stealth device going?"

Anise blinked, then sighed with a slightly rueful smile before straightening. "I was forced to pause my research in order to deal with a new development that greatly concerns the High Council: Your research into synthetic symbionts."

Yes, as Sam had expected.

Entrapta frowned, looking puzzled. "But you knew about that from the start - it was hardly a new development."

"I am talking about the symbionts you are planning to create for humans."

“Oh?” Sam’s friend cocked her head to the side. “Is this about recruiting hosts?” She turned to look at Sam. “We talked about that, right?”

“Yes.” Sam nodded.

“So, you are aware of the effects your research will have on my people?” Anise asked.

“Kinda. But not really.” Entrapta shrugged. “I mean, you only take volunteers as hosts, yes?”

“Of course!”

“But anyone who only wanted a host so they could get healed from an illness or live longer wouldn’t really be volunteering, would they?” Entrapta asked in a guileless tone. “That seems more like a technically-but-not-really voluntary decision - they certainly have a choice, but if one of the choices is so much worse than the other, it’s not really a choice. At least, I think so. You could kinda argue that just having the choice is good enough, but that’s not really true, is it?”

Anise was taken aback. Sam had expected that as well. She felt a little ashamed for letting Entrapta take the lead, so to speak, but while the argument about choices was certainly sound - from an ethical point of view - Sam would have felt a little hypocritical making it herself. Maybe more than a little. She wasn’t a ruthless follower of the idea that the ends justified the means, far from it, but Sam didn’t know what she would be willing to do if humanity’s existence was on the line.

“That’s… true,” Anise said before pressing her lips together for a moment. “But,” she rallied, “sometimes - quite often, actually, as I know - a host would have volunteered without any other incentive anyway if they had known in advance what the bond was like.” Her eyes flashed, and Freya spoke: “Yes. It is hard to describe the feeling to those who haven’t experienced it. “She glanced at Sam

and added: “Or those who have only experienced it in the most extreme circumstances.”

Sam clenched her teeth as she remembered her ‘experience’ with Jolinar.

“But being a host to your partner…” Freya smiled, her eyes looking past Entrapta and Sam. “I would not miss it for the world. You are one half of something greater, something more intimate than you can imagine without living it.”

Oh, Sam could imagine it very well. She had lived through it. To have no secrets left, to feel your most private thoughts, your entire mind, laid open to a stranger… She suppressed a shudder.

“See?” Entrapta beamed. “Our synthetic symbionts won’t really change anything - you’ll still get volunteers.”

Freya’s eyes flashed again, and Anise didn’t look like she shared Entrapta’s optimism. “It is already hard to convince potential hosts that we are nothing like the Goa’uld. This will not make it any easier.”

“Really?” Entrpata pouted a little, “I would have thought that having more people with symbionts would make it more accepted - and not as scary. Some people really fear having a symbiont, even though the benefits are obvious.”

Sam and Anise shared a brief look. “I guess we’ll see,” Sam said, though she didn’t think Entrapta was correct. “But better public relations might improve your chances to find willing hosts significantly.”

“Oh, yes! We can introduce you to Mr Brown and Julie! They’re great at this - they helped us out a lot. People were scared of us as well, can you imagine?”

And they still are, Sam thought. Just not as many as before. Though the recent magical incidents might have changed that again. She didn’t say that, though.

Anise still looked sceptical. "I will have to discuss this with the High Council. I was sent here mainly to get facts about this new… development. I cannot make decisions for my people."

"Oh! Yes, you'll need our data!" Entrapta turned around, hair flying over the keyboard of Sam's secondary computer. "We haven't made too much progress yet - but we found that the base symbiont design should be able to work for both humans and Jaffa, though we'll have to make some changes to allow it to adapt to a human immune system without the Jaffa modifications. You'd think it would be easier to have it work with an actual immune system, but it's not quite as easy since the human immune system wasn't designed for a symbiont."

It's a very good thing, Sam thought, that this is an Etherian research project.

Her superiors, especially her government, would not be happy at all about such data being shared so easily.

Oh.

She closed her eyes for a moment. Some of them - like the Secretary of Defense - who were counting on getting a symbiont themselves to extend their lives might even see sharing data about symbionts with aliens as a threat to their own safety. Like giving out medical data about potential vulnerabilities for biological warfare or whatever else they could come up with.

Well, that was their problem. No one would be forcing them to get a symbiont. In fact, it might be a good thing if this would make some of them hesitate at least a little.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 6th, 1999

"...and amidst unconfirmed reports of magical assaults across Europe, and dangerous 'cryptids' sightings across the world, the

Alliance blindly focuses on the war against the Goa'uld - aliens that have supposedly been forced off Earth by our ancient ancestors with swords and spears yet should be seen as a dire threat to our world! How much longer will this travesty be allowed to go on while people…"

Catra rolled her eyes and muted the channel. You were supposed to keep tabs on your enemies, but she could only stomach watching American media so far. "So much for the Freedom of the Press," she muttered as she leaned back in her seat in the meeting room. A few more minutes until the meeting would begin. "Freedom to lie, more likely."

"That's just a nutcase they interviewed," Adora pointed out, finishing the soda she had grabbed on the way. "The news doesn't actually say that."

Catra shrugged. "If they put him on air, they spread his lies. It works out the same." She glanced at the screen. The politician on air had been replaced by another person being interviewed - if you could call asking them for a quote an interview.

"Not exactly," Daniel objected. "Showing such interviews and contrasting them with facts exposes the claims of those people as false and undermines their reputation and following."

"Really?" Catra scoffed and pressed unmute on the remote on the table.

"...and now the perfidy of the aliens has been exposed! Fell sorcery has been revealed as the evil that it always was! They have deceived those with weak hearts, fooled them with false promises, to lure them astray and corrupt them with magic and false gods! But there is only one saviour, and we know his words as true! It's only by following him that we shall be saved - and he told us to reject both false gods and magic! Thou shalt not suffer a witch to live! He helped our ancestors to drive away alien invaders, and he will help us to do the same if only we have faith! Do not…"

She raised her eyebrows as she muted the television again.

Daniel winced for a moment. "Well, most people will be repelled by such rhetoric."

"And how many people will believe it?" Catra scoffed again. "It's not as if everyone cares about facts in the first place." Some of those lunatics were calling Adora the 'anti-Christ'!

Daniel frowned at that. "We - the Alliance - have been examining those claims and reports. We haven't found any confirmed sightings of such 'cryptids' after Halloween. And most of the magical assaults were rather questionable, to say the least. It seems comparable to the kind of mass hysteria that we saw happen in the past, such as the reports of Japanese attacks on the West Coast following Pearl Harbour in World War II that turned out to be imaginary." He perked up. "But that passed, and this will pass as well."

Catra didn't think it would. Those people were clinging to their delusions no matter the facts. They knew that the only one who could be their 'anti-Christ' was actually a Goa'uld, Sokar, yet refused to consider the implications of that.

"Let's hope so," Adora said with a deep frown.

"It is difficult to make people change their faith even with clear evidence that they are worshipping false gods unworthy of devotion," Teal'c spoke up. "But we shall persevere."

The door opened, and O'Neill stepped inside, followed by Sam and Entrapta. "Sorry for being late," he said with a grin. "We had to get more coffee for Daniel."

"What?" Daniel frowned at him. "I didn't… you don't have any coffee!" he added with a pout.

"It was so good, we drank it on the way." O'Neill shrugged.

"Our shuttle was late," Sam clarified with a slight sigh that Catra's ears picked up.

"Hey! That wasn't my fault!" O'Neill protested. "I was at the spacelab on time. I recall a pair of scientists taking their time boarding their ride."

"We had to finish an experiment," Entrapta explained as she sat down at the table. "Are Glimmer and Bow not coming?"

"Something came up at Bright Moon," Catra said. "So, Sparkles has to smooth ruffled feathers or something, and Bow stayed with her so she won't lose her temper and teleport some idiot into the sea or something."

"Catra!" Adora scolded her. "Micah called for Glimmer to settle an issue between Bright Moon and the Crimson Waste," she told the others. "Anyway, it won't affect our planning session. Entrapta, Sam, you have the latest intel from the spy bots?"

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta nodded and used a tool to project a picture on the wall behind her. "We've mapped the entire planet in greater detail now - it took a while since they have Death Gliders patrolling the orbitals, so the bots had to avoid them, but it wasn't too difficult since there are just a few patrols, not enough to completely cover the planet. You just have to be careful - we could sneak a stealth shuttle through without a problem, according to their search patterns. And speaking of stealth, we have the stealth bots ready for the Stargate. All we need now is the Tok'ra's cover. And Anise said she'd get us that, even though they're probably still unhappy about the symbionts. But as soon as we have a cover for the gate activation, we can send the bots through and look for an ambush."

And once that was dealt with, they could go through themselves. Catra grinned, flashing her fangs. It had been a bit too long since their last time in the field. This should be good.

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Gate Area, PZ-1151, November 8th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill stepped around one of the new stealth bots hovering to the side of the Stargate without the stealth mode engaged on his way to where Carter and Entrapta had set up their computers in one of the new Alliance Standard Mobile Buildings around the D.H.D. - the soldiers were still trying to come up with a decent nickname for the things. Jack was partial to 'Asbies', but generals didn't get to decide that, alas.

Two of the large combat bots - the improved versions capable of anti-air work - were standing guards on each side of the building, with another next to the shield generator in the back. Between those three, the nine others forming a perimeter around the gate and the twelve more standing ready to be deployed, even a few squadrons of Death Gliders would not last long should they get in range. At least according to testing - the bots hadn't seen combat yet.

But the platoon of Jack's 'Snake Hunters' waiting to the side of the Stargate included a few Stinger teams, just in case. And Isa with her blaster cannon.

And there was Emily, standing guard in front of the building. The bot beeped a greeting at Jack, her definitely not-standard blaster cannon and other things Jack was pretty sure he hadn't seen before pointed at the gate.

He nodded back and entered the building.

"There's Jack!" Entrapta called out from where she was standing behind a computer console next to the D.H.D. with Carter. "We're about ready here!"

He looked at Carter, who nodded. "The temporary field base is operational, sir."

A big name for a building and a few fences, but technically correct. Though Jack felt a sudden bout of nostalgia for Stargate Command. Just a bit, though.

“We’re only waiting for your troops,” Catra added. She was sitting - or lounging - on a seat in the back, next to the main screen.

“We’re ready as well,” Jack said. “We were waiting for you,” he added with a grin.

“Sure you were.” Catra smirked.

Adora cleared her throat. “With the temporary field base operational and the forces ready… Start the mission.”

“Yes!” Entrapta turned, and her hair fanned out, flying over the keyboards.

“Dialing to Chulak,” Carter reported as she turned the D.H.D.

The main screen in front of her changed from showing the various parts of the base’s perimeter to the view from the stealth bot, just in time to catch the wormhole stabilising.

“Go, Stealth Bot-7!” Entrapta called out.

Jack could see the bot vanish from sight on the cameras watching it before he focused on the feed from the bot. There, the wormhole grew larger as the bot flew over, then was interrupted for a moment as it entered the gate.

And then they were looking at the deserted area around Chulak’s Stargate.

“Scanning… scanning…” Entrapta reported.

Various numbers and data flickered over the side screens, too fast for Jack to catch them.

“No sign of any bombs,” Carter announced. “Or any high-power device in the area. Trace amounts of Naquadah are at expected levels. Biological and chemical scans continue.”

“Oh! There’s a Naquada device buried in the sand! Take a closer scan!”

The picture zoomed in, then switched to a sort of x-ray view of a…

“It’s a broken zat.” Entrapta sounded disappointed. “No power left in its cell.”

“No sign of a chemical or biological agent,” Carter reported.

“Good. So, the gate area should be safe,” Adora said.

“Relatively safe,” Catra said. “Someone’s bound to be watching for new arrivals. Even on a backwater planet like this.”

“Catra!” Adora frowned at her. “It’s Teal’c’s home!”

“I am not offended, Commander Adora,” Teal’c said. “Chulak is a rather neglected part of Apophis’s realm. Although…” He tilted his head and stared at the feed from the bot. “Those tracks there seem unusual.”

“Tracks? Where?” Entrapta asked.

But Teal’c was right. There was something. Jack took a closer look at the picture on the screen. “Fly closer to the area near the bush there,” he said. “And zoom in.”

They did. It looked like a typical dirt road linking the Stargate with the planetary capital, but the grass to both sides of it…”

“A formation marched through there. Recently,” Teal’c stated. “Four warriors wide.”

If Teal’c said so, it was true. And four warriors wide… that meant a lot of Jaffa.

“That’s unusual,” Catra commented.

“Indeed.”

“We have no records from orbital surveillance of such a troop movement,” Carter reported. “But our coverage has been spotty until a few days ago.”

“Well, did they arrive - or did they leave?” Jack asked.

“I would have to take a closer look in person to tell,” Teal’c said. “Your technology is superb, Entrapta, Sam Carter, Bow, but certain things can’t be done remotely.”

“Well, folks, time to don our disguises,” Jack said. “And look like smugglers.”

Catra snorted as she got up from her seat. “They’re just cloaks. Ratty cloaks.”

“Exactly!” Jack grinned.

“Most of the people plying that trade in the false god’s realms do dress like that,” Teal’c said. “We will not stand out - at least from a distance.”

“And it’s a cover the Tok’ra have used a lot,” Glimmer said.

“Let’s hope the Goa’uld haven’t wised up, then,” Catra said.

“Well, we’ll find out,” Jack said with a little more confidence than he felt. They had enough firepower waiting here to deal with pretty much everything that Apophis was supposed to have on Chulak and then some, and their spy bots hadn’t detected anything from orbit, but… a planet was damn large, and Apophis wasn’t stupid. Still, between the bots - each with the firepower of a main battle tank - Jack’s platoon of the best of his command and She-Ra and her friends, they should be able to outfight any Jaffa infantry force long enough to retreat through the gate. As long as they didn’t have dozens of Death Gliders or a few Al’keshs. And none of their surveillance had showed such forces. If they were hidden on Chulak… well, they should have enough warning to retreat anyway.

He slipped his own cloak on, adjusting it so he could get his carbine out without getting it tangled up. It felt more than a bit like being back on a covert op in certain African regions.

As he and the others approached the Stargate, he saw his platoon get up as well - and pull their own cloaks on. Eager for their first mission, but they'd have to wait for the clear from Jack. Smugglers didn't come in platoon-sized groups.

Jack nodded at them, then went up the ramp and stepped through the Stargate. General or not, he led from the front.

A moment that felt longer than it was later, he was on Chulak. He glanced around, hand on his gun, as the rest arrived, but there was nothing nearby.

Or so it seemed.

Teal'c went straight to the tracks he had spotted, kneeling down. "They went through the gate," he said. "And they came from the capital."

"So… more recruits for Apophis's army?" Daniel speculated. "Marched off to join his main focus?"

That was one possible explanation. And it would fit the rest of their information - mainly the lack of any footage of those troops.

"I do not think so."

Jack turned to look at Teal'c. His friend had sounded… not nearly as stoic as usual in such situations. Almost tense, actually.

Teal'c was holding up a broken necklace which must have been half-buried in the sand, judging by the amount of dirt on it. And he was staring at it with such an intense expression…

"This was Drey'auc's."

*****

The Symbionts Part 3

Gate Area, Chulak, November 8th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"I gave this to Drey'auc on the day we wed."

Adora bit her lower lip as Teal'c carefully brushed dirt from the broken necklace. If this was his wife's…

"Could she have lost it here when she was travelling? Or meeting someone?" Glimmer asked.

"She would not have had any reason to go to the Chappa'ai," he went on. "Not as an outcast. And it was half-buried under a sandal footprint. Not a boot."

"So, she dropped it? As a warning for you?" Catra asked.

Teal'c slowly nodded. "I believe so."

Adora could tell that Catra didn't agree - her lover had that guilty expression she usually had when she wanted to say something but didn't because it might hurt - but it could be true.

"Ah… But no one should have expected our arrival, should they?" Daniel said, cocking his head.

"If she - and Rya'c - were taken by Apophis's forces, then she would have known it was because of me," Teal'c said. "This would have been one of the ways available to her to leave a notice for me. Or for Master Bra'tac," he added after a moment, "to pass on to me."

Catra shrugged. "Either way, we now know that she was taken through the gate. Or that we are supposed to think that."

"Or that Apophis wants us to know," Jack said. "Can't really use hostages if no one knows you have them."

“Whatever may be the truth, we have to find out more about what happened,” Teal’c said. “Master Bra’tac would know more. Even as Shol’va, some of his former students respect him.”

Unless he was taken as well. Or killed. But Adora didn’t say that. She nodded instead. “Then let’s find him!” That was what they had come to Chulak for, anyway.

“Yeah, let’s find a master warrior who just went into hiding on his home planet after the enemy army captured friends of his,” Catra muttered. “Piece of cake.”

Adora frowned at her. “I’m sure we’ll manage.”

“Well, we can scan for Goa’uld larvae,” Entrapta said. “It’s going to be a bit difficult, what with so many Jaffa on the planet, but if he’s hiding from most of them, we should be able to narrow things down. It will take a while, though.” She pushed a button on the scanner, looked at it and added: “A long while, actually.”

“If we do not find Master Bra’tac, I am certain that he will find us,” Teal’c said. “In fact, I would not be surprised if he has already found us.”

“Really?” Glimmer looked sceptical and looked around. “We’re covering the entire area with our scanners.”

But Teal’c wasn’t looking at their surroundings. He was looking at the hills - or the mountains - in the distance.

“You think he’s watching us through a telescope,” Jack said.

Teal’c nodded.

“Since it passively uses visible light and doesn’t require a power supply, it wouldn’t show up on any scanner,” Sam said.

“But the resolution… you’d have to have a huge telescope to have a decent resolution,” Entrapta retorted. “That should show up on our scanners.”

“Master Bra’tac would not need more than a glimpse of us to draw his conclusions,” Teal’c said, still looking at the hills. “He will not approach us here, though.”

“I can teleport us there,” Glimmer said. “If we activate Chulak’s magic.”

“We’re not activating magic on a planet under Goa’uld control just because you’re too lazy to walk,” Catra snapped.

“It’s not about walking!” Glimmer protested. “But we can’t waste time.”

“And we can’t let the other Jaffa who are undoubtedly watching us see us teleport away anyway,” Jack added. “That would alert them.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded at Entrapta. “Tell the others to close the Stargate and stand by - we’re going to walk. Like smugglers.”

“Alright!”

Behind them, the gate disappeared, and Adora’s comm lit up with a few alerts as it switched to the Spy Bots in orbit, connecting to their network to maintain contact with PZ-1151. The lag would be annoying, but shouldn’t be crippling. And far less suspicious than keeping a Stargate open.

They left one bot in stealth mode to watch the gate and marched off towards the hills in the distance. Teal’c had picked their destination.

Halfway to the hills, Teal’c suddenly stopped.

“Teal’c?” Jack asked.

“I saw a short glint ahead of us. A piece of metal must have caught the light from the sun. Or a mirror.”

“Or a scope,” Catra muttered. “Could be an ambush.”

“There’s nothing on our orbital surveillance, but it’s a little spotty in orbit, and the area is forested,” Entrapta said. “Though there’s a single larva there, probably,” she added after a moment. “I need a bit more time to scan the area in detail.”

“Master Bra’tac chooses his hiding spots well.”

“If you’re sure…” Jack trailed off as Adora spotted another glint in the distance.

Teal’c inclined his head. “Indeed.”

“Yes, that’s a larva according to the scanner. So, a Jaffa,” Entrapta said, peering through her goggles. “I’m trying to vector in a spy bot in orbit so we get better coverage, but there’s a Death Glider in the way.”

“Let’s just continue,” Adora said. She trusted Teal’c. If he said this was Bra’tac, then they could go on.

“Yeah, let’s. I’m not fond of standing around in the open on an enemy planet,” Jack agreed. “Or an enemy anything.”

“We’re looking like smugglers,” Catra said. “Don’t tell me I’m squishing my ears flat and wrapping my tail around myself for nothing.”

Adora looked at her, raising her eyebrows. Sure, it wasn’t too comfortable, but it wasn’t as if it was hurting her - Catra’s ears could take a lot of squishing, and her tail was very flexible, as they had proven often enough. Not that this was the time to think about that!

But it also wasn’t the time to complain. They weren’t on a march in cadet training. And it hadn’t been the time to complain then, either!

“We should get some stealth transports that can fit through a Stargate,” Glimmer said as if she had read Adora’s mind and

wanted to disagree on principle. But she was walking - and Catra followed suit. As expected.

"We'll have to find a way to reduce the stealth generator even further," Entrapta said. "So far, we haven't managed that - the best of our designs was a shuttle that could use a stealth generator and barely fit the Stargate but, well, couldn't really do anything else. Like transporting people. Upscaling a stealth bot ran into the same issue, just from the other direction, so to speak. People just need so much space and life support and everything! Anise is working on a portable stealth generator using a different technology, but… she hasn't had any luck in making a generator that hasn't lethal side effects yet. But she's working on it."

Uh. Adora grimaced.

"You know what? I am just fine walking!" Bow said.

"Me too!" Daniel agreed, nodding eagerly. "A bit of walking won't kill us."

Both started to walk a little faster. As did everyone else.

*****

They reached the hills half an hour later. That would have been quite a good time for their squad back in cadet training. Not quite a forced march, but faster than regular infantry - Horde or Earth.

And next to the trail they had been following was the man they were looking for, waiting for them under a tree with a dense canopy, next to a large rock that would shield him from the plains and the Stargate.

"Master Bra'tac." Teal'c nodded at him

"Teal'c. O'Neill. Carter. Jackson." Bra'tac nodded at them, then looked at Adora and her friends. "And new friends."

“Yes.” Teal’c turned a little. “They are new friends - and mighty allies. Master Bra’tac, this is She-Ra, Princess of Power. Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon. Princess Entrapta of Dryl. Techmaster Bow of Bright Moon. Catra.”

“Of nothing,” Catra added with a smirk as she pushed her hood back and shook her head, her ears twitching.

“A Sekhmet?” Bra’tac tilted his head like Teal’c often did before frowning slightly. “No, not quite, I believe - but I have only seen pictures, and that had been a hundred years ago.”

“No, I’m not a Sekhmet,” Catra said, rolling her eyes. “You’re not the first to make this mistake.” She flashed her fangs in a grin.

“Catra’s from Etheria, the result of genetic engineering by the First Ones - which you know as the Ancients or the Gate Builders, I believe,” Entrapta spoke up. “Like me and Glimmer.” She demonstrated her power, her hair fanning out and holding various tools. “And Bow probably has some ancestor who was experimented on as well if we look at the time that has passed since then and the average human generation and tendency to intermarry, even if that genetic ancestry hasn’t expressed itself through magic powers. Glimmer can’t demonstrate her own magic power since it relies on more magic in the world than my own, which doesn’t need nearly as much, so what energy my body can spare is enough, and we haven’t restored the planet’s magic yet because doing so would kinda draw a lot of attention which would be a bad thing, probably, but Adora can demonstrate her own magic, just in case you won’t believe us - many seem to have forgotten about magic being real since it was taken from the sector a thousand years ago.”

Jack sighed and closed his eyes for a moment, probably complaining about secrecy, but Bra’tac blinked, his own eyebrows raising, as Adora noticed. He turned to look at Teal’c.

“Entrapta speaks the truth,” Teal’c said. “I have personally witnessed their powers and seen the proof of their claims.”

“I see. And you’re fighting the false gods.”

“Yes,” Adora said.

“A lot of things have changed on Earth since our last meeting,” Jack said, smiling a bit wrily. “We’ve formed an alliance against the Goa’uld, and we’re preparing to go to war - well, technically, we’re already at war, but the Goa’uld don’t know yet.”

Bra’tac looked at them. “I have not heard of Etheria so far, but you must be mighty indeed if you plan to openly battle the false gods.”

That was a question more than a comment. Though Adora could understand that Bra’tac would be sceptical of their claims. It was a lot to take in.

“We’ve defeated Horde Prime,” Catra said.

Bra’tac’s eyes widened. “I know that name. The Goa’uld did not wish to fight him. And you defeated him.”

Adora sighed. Catra made it sound as if they had more power than Horde Prime had had. “It’s a bit complicated,” she said.

“Etheria has technology on par with the Gate Builders,” Teal’c said. “And many of Horde Prime’s surviving ships and soldiers now fight for them. On Earth, a great army is gathering, preparing to liberate the slaves of the false gods.” He took a step forward. “And they have found a way to free us for good from the hold of the Goa’uld. They found a way to replace Prim’tas. No longer will we have to choose between freedom and life. We came to Chulak to inform you.”

Bra’tac looked almost shocked, then smiled. “That’s the best news I’ve heard in my long life, my friend. And yet, I have to tell you ill news in return,” he added, his expression turning sombre.

Teal’c nodded. “I’ve found Drey’auc’s necklace at the Stargate.”

"Your wife and your son were taken by the Serpent Guard," Bra'tac said. "I am sorry."

*****

Eastern Hills, Chulak, November 8th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"You could not have done anything, my friend."

"I could have. If I had heard about it beforehand, I could have warned them. Taken them to safety. But I have few friends left in the Serpent Guards, and none of them are on Chulak."

You have contacts in Apophis's forces? Of course, you do, Samantha Carter thought. Bra'tac had shown that on Klorel's ship. Teal'c wasn't the only Jaffa Bra'tac had taught to question the Goa'uld, just the most prominent and arguably most successful rebel.

"Even the most skilled Warrior is beholden to the whims of chance. You taught me that."

Bra'tac nodded with a faint smile. "I did. We cannot change what happened."

"But we can attempt to remedy it."

Sam almost expected the Colonel to make a sarcastic comment about philosophy lessons, but he held his tongue.

"They were taken to Saqqara, that much I was able to discern," Bra'Tac said after the briefest pause.

That was Apophis's home world. P2Z-275. Sam pressed her lips together - blurting out Stargate Command's designation might prompt some teasing remark from the Colonel, and this wasn't the time for that.

"So, we have to go there and free them," Daniel said. He looked uncharacteristically eager, Sam noted. Oh. Of course, he would -

Sha’re was likely on Saqqara as well. And if she wasn’t, information about her location would likely be available in Apophis’s capital. Daniel saw an opportunity to save his wife and Teal’c’s family.

Sam hated it, and herself a little for saying it, but she had to. “Apophis’s home world will be heavily guarded. We don’t have spy bot coverage there. Any attempt at infiltration will be very difficult without sufficient intel.” And dangerous. Very dangerous.

“What about an invasion?” Daniel asked. “A decapitation strike? Saqqara is a core part of Apophis’s realm, one of the worlds supplying his forces. If we could take it out, he would be greatly weakened. The other System Lords would turn on him.”

“We would have to hold it.” Teal’c shook his head slightly. “That would most likely reveal the Alliance to the Goauld at large. Even if we decided to merely destroy the arms factories on the planet before leaving, witnesses would remain. I do not believe that the Alliance currently has the resources to launch a false flag operation of that scale. And if our existence becomes known to the System Lords, they will close ranks.”

“Yeah.” The Colonel looked grim. “We would need a fleet of Ha’taks to take on Apophis’s home fleet without revealing ourselves.”

“We could develop a form of camouflage technology that would allow a frigate to mimic a Ha’tak, maybe,” Entrapta suggested. “Using holoprojection and stealth technology to fool sensors, it might be possible, though the differences in weapon technology would be a challenge to mask. The weapon placements are different, as are the flight profiles.”

“It would probably be easier to construct Ha’taks - or facsimiles with our technology,” Sam said. And that would be far too inefficient when they were still struggling to build their own shops on Earth. But a system that allowed their ships to pose as Ha’taks would be useful as well. It would allow them to close in with

enemy ships and installations, at the least, before dropping the facade. Although whether or not such advantages were worth the resources needed to develop those systems was questionable… Sam shook her head. She could run a feasibility study another time.

"You think you have the forces to take and hold Apophis's homeworld?" Bra'tac once more tilted his head.

"Yes," She-Ra replied. "But we don't have the numbers to defend every world we liberate against a Goa'uld fleet and keep doing it until everyone's saved. We need to destroy the Goa'uld's fleets before we can start freeing all their enslaved worlds to keep them from massing their forces for retaliatory strikes."

"Or use a few worlds as bait to lure those fleets into battles where we can destroy them," Catra added. "Hunting down all of their ships and fleets would be a pain."

"I see." Bra'tac nodded.

"But that will take a long time," Daniel said. "Teal'c's family needs help now. And Sha're…" He trailed off, pressing his lips together.

"Without the Spy Bot Network, we need other ways to get intel," Glimmer said. "Originally, we came to spread the news about the symbionts. Can those be used to convince more people to turn against Apophis so they would supply us with information?"

Bra'tac slowly tilted his head. "If they work, yes. But they would have to be demonstrated - even those who question the false gods will not easily turn to sabotage, much less open rebellion. If I had a few examples…"

"We are ramping up production," Entrapta said. "So, we don't have too many yet - but we're working on that, don't worry! Once the factories are running, we'll do what we can to cover everyone! But we have a few with us - Sam expected this! Well, we have them at the temporary base camp."

Sam nodded. “We can move back there and demonstrate their use.” And replace your own Prim’ta, she silently added. She didn’t know how old Bra’tac’s symbiont was, but she was certain that before making any promises to his friends, he would test the symbionts himself. But unlike certain politicians, he wouldn’t do it for selfish reasons but to ensure if anyone got hurt, it would be him and not others.

“Yes, let’s retreat off-planet for now,” the Colonel said.

“But…” Daniel closed his mouth with a glance at Teal’c.

“It is the wisest course of action, for now,” Teal’c said. “We need more information to plan our next move. We might have to appeal to the Tok’ra for their support.”

“The Tok’ra?” Bra’tac’s eyebrows rose again. “You are in contact with them?”

“We’re allies,” the Colonel said. “Kind of. It’s complicated.”

“It’s not. We *are* allies. And friends. They are just stuck in their spy ways,” Adora retorted.

“As I said, it’s complicated.”

“I see. I think.” Bra’tac nodded.

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Gate Area, PZ-1151, November 8th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“So… here’s our Temporary Healing Station. Or Temporary Medical Station, depending on whether you have a healer available or not. Since we have Adora with us, it’s a Healing Station. Which actually means that whatever station she visits turns into a Healing Station, I think.” Entrapta frowned a little. “That seems a bit weird. Logical, but weird even for the militaries of Earth and their traditions.”

Catra snorted. The Earth military did love their abbreviations and definitions. They had their uses, of course, but sometimes, they took it too far. A bit of flexibility was often better for running an army, in her experience. A lesson she had, fortunately, in hindsight, learned late.

"Only staff permanently assigned to a station counts for the designation," Sam told her.

"Ah. That makes more sense. Anyway, we can test the symbiont - well, demonstrate it; we already tested it - in there," Entrapta told Bra'tac. "The station isn't currently busy treating wounded since we didn't fight, and there were no accidents."

"Is this standard of care for your wounded?" Bra'tac asked, looking around as they entered the station.

"It depends on the missions," O'Neill explained. "If we establish a field base, even a temporary one like this, then yes, it will have a medical centre. But we wouldn't do this on planets we don't control or are about to conquer."

"Liberate," Glimmer corrected him. "We aren't going to conquer any planets. We're going to liberate them from the Goa'uld."

Catra snorted again. The Princess Alliance sometimes was a little too concerned with semantics as well. To defeat the Goa'uld, the Alliance would have to take a lot of worlds and base troops on them - to protect them from a counter-attack, but also to fight whatever loyalist remnants were left on the world. The differences between that and outright conquest would be minimal until the planet was ready to fend for itself, and that would take a long time with most undeveloped worlds.

Glimmer was frowning at her, Catra noticed. She snorted again and shrugged. "We're not going to form an Empire. But we're not going to liberate a planet and then leave it for anyone else to conquer or raid."

"We're from the Alliance, and we're here to help," O'Neill added.

"Yes!" Adora must have missed that he was sarcastic and nodded eagerly. "We're here to help the Goa'uld's victims - all of them!"

Daniel opened his mouth, then closed it, scowling at O'Neill.

"Anyway," Entrapta spoke up again, her hair pointing at a reinforced small tank in the corner with a guard bot hovering next to it. "There are two dozen synthetic symbionts. Pick one, and we can implant it in you right away! It works just like a Goa'uld larva for your immune system, and that's all it does. And it will last for decades - we don't know exactly how long it will last, only that it will be at least a few decades. It's kind of hard to test that any faster, so we have to extrapolate from other data."

The old Jaffa walked over and peered at the armoured glass. He was almost a hundred and forty years old, according to Teal'c. Older than anyone Catra knew, except for Angella. And Horde Prime. What would it be like, to be that old? she wondered.

"They do look differently from Prim'tas."

"Yes. We had to stick to a similar form so they could interface with your immune system, but a lot of the other parts were unnecessary, so we cut them - well, figuratively. We didn't actually cut pieces from a Goa'uld larva. It's all genetic engineering!"

"I would cut countless Prim'tas to free even one of my people," Bra'tac said.

Daniel nodded quite fiercely, to Catra's surprise.

"Well, we don't have to do that," Adora said.

But they would have to deal with every Prim'ta that they replaced. And Catra had a feeling that their former hosts would want to dispose of them. Permanently. She understood that. Very well. It had taken everything not to smash Horde Prime's chip as soon as it had been removed, back when… She pressed her lips together.

“Anyway, we can replace your larva any time you’re ready!” Entrapta said. “It’s very easy since you have a pouch made for that - it would be a bit harder if we had to do surgery, but only a bit.”

Bra’tac looked at Teal’c. “You have not yet replaced your Prim’ta.”

“I thought a demonstration might be necessary for some who might doubt it,” Teal’c replied. “But I am ready to replace it as well.”

“Bye-bye, Junior,” Catra heard O’Neill mutter. “And good riddance.”

“Then we shall do so,” Bra’tac announced.

“Great!” Entrapta cheered. “We can do it simultaneously!”

The actual procedure was… well, not really a procedure. Teal’c and Bra’tac sat down on one of the surgical tables, Entrapta and Sam each grabbed a synthetic symbiont from the tank, and then the two Jaffa pulled their belly pouch open, reached inside and pulled the Prim’tas out before putting the synthetic symbionts in.

For some reason, most of the Earth people in the room looked a little taken aback, though. Or grossed out.

“Alright! Let’s use our scanner to check…” Entrapta said, hair tendrils pointing two scanners from the station’s stock at the two Jaffa. “Looks good. No signs of any collapse… data matches our baselines from testing… You’re good!” She beamed at Teal’cand Bra’tac.

“We’re free,” Bra’tac said.

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded.

The two exchanged a glance and a nod, and then Catra heard a squishing noise, followed by the sound of Goa’uld blood and body parts dripping on the floor.

“Ew!”

“Gross!”

“That was…”

“Was that necessary?”

“That’s not sanitary, I think, for a medical station. We’ll have to sterilise the area thoroughly.”

Catra shook her head. What had her friends expected that Teal’c and Bra’tac would do, once free? She’d done the same - well, she would have shredded it with her claws, but the result would have been the same.

*****

Well, I should have expected that, Jack O’Neill thought as Teal’c and Bra’tac washed their hands while a small bot started to clean and disinfect the mess on the floor. If you were forced to carry a larva of your worst enemy inside you on pain of death for years - decades - then killing it as soon as you could was a natural impulse. It probably also felt cathartic, not that he’d ever use the word aloud - Jack had a reputation to keep.

He glanced at the others. Carter had that expression on her face, lips pressed together, trying not to scowl, that showed she disapproved but wouldn’t say anything because she didn’t disapprove too much. Or understood the reasons. And Daniel… didn’t look like he disapproved at all. He would be thinking of his wife. Though for a guy like him not to react to this… Jack made a mental note to keep an eye on that. Daniel was usually the voice of restraint and mercy, and if he wasn’t, you had to watch out.

The Etherians, unsurprisingly, were openly appalled - with the equally unsurprising exception of Catra. Although Jack wasn’t quite sure if Entrapta was appalled at the killing or the unhygienic way it had happened.

“Was that necessary?” Adora repeated herself when Teal’c and Bra’tac finished cleaning up - well, mostly; there were a few Goa’uld blood spots left on their clothes.

Bra’tac tilted his head - was that where Teal’c got it from? - and nodded. “It was more merciful than letting them die from exposure.”

“We could have put the larvae into a tank,” Bow said.

“To what purpose? So it can grow into a Goa’uld, and we have to kill it then?” Bra’tac shook his head.

“We don’t kill prisoners!” Adora snapped.

Jack caught Bra’tac glancing at Teal’c for confirmation.

“Indeed. Yet, larvae are not prisoners,” Teal’c added. “They would have to mature for that.”

“They carry the genetic memory of their Goa’uld parent - although to what degree varies - but as far as we know, they are not sapient yet and cannot access it,” Carter said. She looked uncomfortable, though.

“But they will if you let them grow up,” Daniel added with a scowl. “They will look for hosts to possess - we know that - and fight us.”

“They might join the Tok’ra,” Adora retorted.

“Those who join the Tok’ra do so after their experiences under their Goa’uld lords,” Teal’c said. “And a very scant few of the Goa’uld ever overcome their genetic memory.”

“How can you fight a war if you intend to breed your enemies?” Bra’tac asked.

“That’s not the point,” Glimmer said.

“What else would you do with them?” Daniel asked. “Incubate them to keep them in habitats? Do you know how many larvae a single Goa’uld queen produces? And you know they require sapient hosts to be mentally healthy. Do you want larvae to mature, just to live like that?”

The Etherians obviously didn’t like it, but they didn’t have an answer to that. Jack nodded. Daniel always knew how to ask the hard questions.

“Well… we could try to find a way to fix them so they won’t be diminished if they lack a sapient host?” Entrapta suggested. “It should be possible with genetic engineering.”

And Entrapta always knew how to make an awkward situation even worse by opening a huge can of worms. Almost literally, in this case.

“Entrapta! We can’t just ‘fix’ an entire species!” Glimmer said.

“Why not? We’re working on finding a way to fix the Asgard’s issues. This seems to be the same problem. Sameish.”

“We can’t just fix a species against their will,” Glimmer corrected herself. “I mean, we shouldn’t.”

“So we should kill them instead?” Entrapta asked.

“Yes,” Bra’tac said.

“Indeed.”

“No!” Adora shook her head. “But we can’t make that decision for them. That would be wrong.”

“But we have to think about how to handle the Goa’uld if we win the war,” Catra spoke up. “What do we do with them?”

“Let the Tok’ra decide?” Bow suggested.

“They do not consider themselves Goa’uld,” Carter pointed out.

“Yes, Anise was very clear about that.” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “So, if we shouldn’t decide the fate of another species, then the Tok’ra shouldn’t either, right?”

“Just pick a planet with lots of swamps and water and drop all of them into it, then seal it off?” Catra shrugged.

“As far as we know, they did evolve in such circumstances,” Daniel added. “If they had not managed to possess sapient hosts, they would still be restricted to their home planet. Banishing them back to that planet would merely let nature run its course.”

Jack didn’t think things worked like that, but he didn’t have a better suggestion. Not that he needed one. “That’s all fine and dandy, but we haven’t won the war yet. We have not yet begun to fight, so to speak.”

Daniel frowned at him for mangling and misusing the famous quote, but the others nodded.

“That still leaves us with the problem of how to handle larvae,” Glimmer said. “Every Jaffa we free from the Goa’uld’s hold on them will have one.”

“And every Jaffa will kill it to free themselves,” Bra’tac said. “Are you planning to deny them this?”

“One could argue that we don’t have the right to deprive them of exacting justice according to their customs,” Daniel said.

“The Alliance doesn’t kill prisoners,” Adora retorted. “And we won’t look away while prisoners are killed by others.”

“But are larvae prisoners?” Entrapta asked. “If they aren’t sapient, they can’t really be prisoners.” She nodded. “We need data! We’ll have to test if they are sapient or not!”

Jack saw Carter nod at that and suppressed a groan. He had a feeling that this would further complicate things. "Yeah, good, you do that. But first, let's focus on saving Teal'c's family."

Everyone agreed to that, at least. Not that Jack had expected anything else. It was what SG-1 and their friends did, after all.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 8th, 1999

"You want to attack Apophis's homeworld?" General Naird sounded shocked, Adora found. For the highest-ranking American officer in the Alliance Command Council, he seemed to be a bit… easily startled.

"No, we want to rescue Teal'c's family," she explained - again.

"By attacking Apophis's homeworld," Naird repeated himself.

"We're not planning to attack Saqqara," Catra said. "We're going to sneak in, get Drey'auc and Rya'c and leave. Preferably without anyone noticing anything, but if we have to fight our way free, well…" She shrugged.

"What happens happens," Jack added with a grin. "General."

Naird ground his teeth. "I've read the reports from Stargate Command. Your team regularly turned exploration missions into combat missions, *General*!"

"That wasn't our fault," Jack retorted.

"I'm not some rear-echelon paper-pusher - I know a bullshit excuse when I see one, and your reports were full of them!" Naird snarled. "This council agreed that keeping the Alliance a secret is our current strategic priority. Such a mission would jeopardise that!"

“It’s true that this seems to be a slightly risky operation,” Admiral Brown-Emerson said, running a finger over his moustache. “But we have to consider the reward of a successful mission.”

Naird frowned. “As far as I know, both Teal’c’s wife and son are considered outcasts in Jaffa society. The odds that they are privy to classified, actionable intel are low. And I doubt that the targets of opportunity General O’Neill is undoubtedly planning to hit will be worth the risk, either.”

Adora glared at him. That wasn’t how you judged the risks! Teal’c had done so much for the Alliance, risked and sacrificed so much, they owed him this!

“It’s not about the intel we can gather - or the factories we might be able to sabotage - it’s also about weakening Apophis’s hold on his systems,” Glimmer spoke up. “If we can save Drey’auc and Rya’c, everyone will know he cannot even control his homeworld. The loss of face alone will weaken him and encourage defectors and infighting - and attacks from other System Lords.”

“And reveal the Alliance!” Naird objected.

“No, it won’t,” Adora told him. “The Goa’uld will assume that this was just another mission by SG-1. We won’t be recognisable as either Horde or Etherians.” Even though the Goa’uld couldn’t really be aware of Etheria anyway since it had been hidden in Despondo for a thousand years.

“And we have done this before,” Jack added with a smirk. “Not to brag, but we got a reputation amongst the snakes.”

Naird rolled his eyes, then looked at Catra. “Then the Goa’uld should know that Earth doesn’t have… catpeople.”

Adora’s lover snorted. “They’ll think I’m an alien SG-1 picked up somewhere. Maybe a Sekhmet - people keep mistaking me for one.”

“I agree. This would fit Stargate Command’s past exploits,” Admiral Brown-Emerson said.

“But there is a risk of one or more members of the team getting captured,” General Durand pointed out.

“We won’t leave anyone behind,” Adora said, narrowing her eyes. Never again.

“You can’t promise that,” Naird objected.

“Yes, I can.” She looked at him until he pouted.

“It could still go wrong…”

“If the worst happens, what would they do?” Admiral Brown-Emerson asked. “Even if they suspect or assume that Earth has found allies, they wouldn’t know who or where to look for them - except for Earth. And if the Goa’uld rally and attack the Solar System in force, then that would be the perfect opportunity to destroy a significant part of their fleet with our superior forces. Strategically, that would be a very favourable outcome.”

“You’re just hoping for another Trafalgar!” Naird muttered.

“This Council agreed that destroying the enemy’s Naval assets is a necessary step for the liberation of their worlds,” the British admiral replied in a bland tone.

Jack still snickered, of course.

“In any case,” Adora pointed out, “as this is a recon mission, I can authorise it. Which I did.” As Supreme Commander of the Alliance.

They wouldn’t leave Teal’c’s family in Apophis’s hands. Or Sha’re, if she was on Saqqara.

All they needed was the Tok’ra’s help.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 8th, 1999

"You ask for our help to infiltrate Saqqara, Apophis's homeworld."

Anise didn't sound amused, Samantha Carter thought. Although she also sounded surprised, but Sam wasn't sure about that - she was a scientist, not a diplomat. The only reason this discussion was happening in the first place was that Sam and Entrapta were friends with Anise, and this was how Etherian princesses did things. But Sam wasn't a princess, either. This really should be handled by others. Probably not the Colonel, though.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "We need to save Teal'c's family and Daniel's wife. And our data indicates that they are currently on Saqqara - at least the former. We're not quite sure about Sha're, but we should be able to find information about her location on Saqqara as well, I think."

"You might also find death on Saqqara. Or worse." Anise shook her head. "Apophis's court is there, as are his most loyal and effective guards."

"We're aware of the danger," Sam said. It had been pointed out *ad nauseam*, as Daniel had complained, by some members of the Command Council.

"I doubt that." Her friend scoffed. "You have no experience with infiltrating a stronghold of a System Lord, much less their court. Your success against Ra was due to his arrogance and mere chance that he visited Abydos."

Sam suppressed a wince. She couldn't really disagree with that assessment. But she hadn't been on that mission. "Stargate Command achieved more undercover missions." Like the one to Chulak two years ago. And they did blow up two of Apophis's Ha'taks to save Earth, though they had been lucky that time as well.

Anise frowned. “Missions born from desperation that succeeded due to chance do not equal actual experience with this sort of undercover work. There are few amongst the Tok’ra I would call experienced and qualified for such a mission, and it wouldn’t include me.”

“But you do have such people,” Entrapta said, still smiling. “The data you have on Apophis couldn’t be collected without someone on Saqqara.”

Anise frowned, even though that was common knowledge, and the Tok’ra had never denied it. “Yes, we do. And each time they contact us to pass on intel, they risk their lives and years of preparation and sacrifices. You are asking us to risk all that - and the chance of finding crucial information in the future - for what?”

“To save our friends’ families, of course,” Entrapta earnestly replied as if that was enough of a reason. But then, for the Etherians, it was.

Sam smiled wryly at Anise’s expression. It had probably been a rhetorical question.

“And does that justify the risks?”

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded firmly. “No one left behind. Unless they’re dead - but we’ll make sure that they’re dead even if they look dead. That once happened to me, you know? We were infiltrating a Horde base, and I got cut off, and it looked as if I was killed, so the others left. I had managed to escape into an air duct, though, and later met Catra and Scorpia, and then Hordak, so it turned out for the best!” She beamed at them.

Sam didn’t quite agree with that assessment, but it was none of her business. “Both the Etherians and SG-1 have experience with infiltrating enemy strongholds,” she said instead.

“What you told me about your missions doesn’t fill me with confidence about what you learned from those experiences,” Anise retorted. But she was smiling, at least a little.

Sam wasn't a diplomat, but this was a good sign. "We do not want you to risk your agent at court. We only require a cover to use the Stargate to reach Saqqara."

"Yes. If we have to fight our way in, it would make finding our friends' families much harder," Entrapta said. "And we probably would have to invade the planet."

Judging by her friend's expression, Sam was sure that Anise didn't like the implication that the Alliance would launch an invasion if infiltration wasn't possible. Time to push, then. "Our mission would also provide a good cover for any sensitive information your agent passes over - at least for a time, future leaks could be blamed on us. And your agent would have an opportunity to replace a Goa'uld in the wake of the purge that a successful mission would start."

Anis gave her a look that made Sam suspect she had overdone it a little. "Will you also point out that if you happen to kill Apophis in his court, our agent would be free to return anyway?"

Well, that had come up during their discussion - it was bound to since that was how Ra had died - but… "This is a recon and rescue mission, not an assassination mission," Sam told her. Of course, if they stumbled on Apophis, all bets would be off.

Anise nodded. "I see. I will inform the Grand Council about this. But I can make no promises."

Sam knew that. But she had a good feeling about this.

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The Rescue Operation Part 1

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 9th, 1999

"...and while reports of magical attacks in the United States keep accumulating, none of them have been confirmed so far. According to today's press release, the police are investigating all reports of magical assaults to the best of their ability, though the press release didn't specify what exactly those resources are. Will we be seeing witch cops patrolling the neighbourhood on brooms?"

Catra switched channels while the stupid journalist laughed at his own joke.

"...and the Vatican has refused to comment on rumours that, following the recent reports of magical assaults in Britain and other countries, they are considering using the Holy Inquisition for witch hunting as several conservative politicians from various predominantly Catholic countries have demanded. However…"

"...authorities are still investigating the massive oak tree that has sprouted overnight in front of the Stortinget. Security camera footage from the parliament building has been leaked, showing that the tree grew within a few minutes from a sapling pushing through the grass to a towering height of twenty-five metres. Even though no one has yet proposed cutting the tree down, several dozen worshippers of the Norse Pantheon have gathered to protest any harm. According to their spokesperson, they consider the tree a gift from the gods, and…"

"I wonder if we should inform the Asgard of this," Catra commented as she changed channels again.

"Of what?" Adora looked up from the reports she was studying.

"That someone's trying to impersonate them."

Adora blinked. “They are?”

Catra snorted. “I doubt it. Looks more like someone in Norway figured out how to magically grow trees.”

“Oh!” Adora straightened. “Like Perfuma? We need to contact them, then! That could be a great boon to our logistics!”

Catra shrugged. “So far, no one has claimed responsibility. But we should tell the Norwegian Prime Minister.”

“Yes!” Adora made a note.

“Unless it’s limited to trees,” Catra added. “That’s not going to help much. And people might get angry if someone cuts it down.”

“Oh.” Her lover frowned. “That’d be… not good. But we still need to know if someone can grow trees. And how.” She went back to reading her reports, and Catra returned to watching the news.

“...crowds are gathering in front of the temple, hoping to be blessed by what was described as a kami by the local priest, apparently manifesting as a column of water in the temple’s pond. It was reportedly called by a shrine maiden whose name has been withheld. While the Japanese government has not yet commented on it, the Tokyo Police Department is monitoring the situation but has not seen any need to intervene so far, and…”

“...of the New South Wales Police Force announced that travel to the area was restricted after witnesses reported seeing a ‘great black monster dragging a kangaroo into the river’. While experts assume this was a saltwater crocodile, perhaps of uncommon colouration, some sources claim it was a ‘bunyip’, and…”

“If Entrapta constructs a bot to sift through all the Earth news for things that would be of interest, I bet the thing kills itself after a week,” Catra muttered.

“Hm?”

“Nothing.” Catra sighed and changed channels again. The Tok’ra should hurry up; waiting like this was the worst. Especially with the whole world still going crazy about magic.

“...and the police have confirmed that the girl died during an exorcism attempt by the local pastor after her parents complained about her ‘unnatural behaviour’ since Halloween. Dozens of members of the pastor’s church have gathered in front of the jail to protest his arrest. The family of the dead girl also released a statement protesting the arrest. According to them, the pastor only did ‘God’s work’, and…”

Catra shook her head. Crazies! The whole lot of them. Maybe she should stop watching the news and reread some of the reports. But she already read them and memorised everything about Saqqara. She could go bug O’Neill and help with training his ‘Snake Hunters’, but that would require a shuttle trip to Germany and leave Adora. And someone had to keep an eye on her.

She sighed and looked at the screen in their office - well, Adora’s - again.

“...and the police were forced to step in after a ‘miracle’ in the local church was exposed as a simple trick by a group of teenagers. Two people had to be treated in the hospital after the congregation grew violent following their ‘sabotage’ of Paster Lawrence’s service and tried to attack the teenagers, injuring themselves when their car ran into a ditch trying to ram a van…”

Yes, completely crazy! Catra sighed again as a bunch of kids were interviewed while their dog - the size of a pony - stole food out of the journalist’s car. This was…

Her tablet vibrated, interrupting her thoughts. More requests from Etheria for Earth media? They were lucrative but often annoying, especially when they didn’t know what exactly they wanted to watch or read.

It wasn’t an order. It was a message from Entrapta. The Tok’ra had contacted her.

Yes!

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, November 9th, 1999

“Chevron Seven… locked.”

Jack O’Neill watched as the wormhole formed. It still felt weird to be in this new base, with the familiar routines and familiar people, yet no longer being part of Stargate Command.

“Wormhole stabilised.”

He glanced up at the Gate Command Centre, where General Hammond was watching from behind armoured glass. Of course, this base had shield generators ready to isolate the Stargate and blaster turrets to deal with any intruders. They still had soldiers on guard, though. And a sorceress from Etheria - nominally under Jack’s command because of politics. Couldn’t have the Russians and Chinese be in command of sorceresses or Etherians.

“Alright! Let’s go - there’s no time to lose!” Adora said, already stepping on the ramp.

“Bot first,” Catra objected.

“Yes! You wouldn’t want to hurt its feelings, would you?” Entrapta asked.

“And we still have time,” Catra added.

“The delegation might be early,” Adora pointed out while the bot floated through the Stargate. “And if they try to open a Stargate and it doesn’t work…”

“They’ll expect Saqqara’s Stargate to be busy and wait for their scheduled arrival,” Catra retorted. “So, relax.”

“Visual confirmation,” Carter announced.

Jack glanced over to her screen, where a deserted Stargate had appeared - just as it was supposed to look. Then the view changed as the drone looked up into the dark sky above it.

“Tracking constellations… PK-Z642’s location confirmed,” Carter announced.

“No active power source or Naquadah on the scanner,” Entrapta added, watching a feed on her visor.

“Alright. Let’s go. We’ve got an ambush to prepare!” Catra walked past Adora and stepped through the gate.

“Hey!” Adora followed. “You said there was no need to hurry!”

Jack sighed. He knew that the two would be perfectly - well, reasonably - professional once the action started, but… General or not, making jokes before a mission to release the tension was his shtick.

“Let’s go!” he told the rest, walking up the ramp himself and through the gate.

He arrived on PK-Z642. A deserted world with barely any life on it. At least, according to their intel - and that was also exactly how it looked to normal people. Some biologists would probably be all excited about the lichens on the rocks near the Stargate. “Why did the Ancients place a Stargate here?” He shook his head. “They probably had a quota to make or something.”

“That was millions of years ago,” Daniel said, walking down the ramp. “Things must have been different back then.” Glimmer and Bow were close on his heels.

Jack shrugged. “I doubt it. There aren’t even any ruins here.”

“Who cares? It’s an empty planet with an address close enough to Saqqara’s so the Tok’ra can pull off the switch without looking suspicious,” Catra said. “That’s all we need.”

“Well, discovering a planet’s history might reveal valuable information.” Daniel smiled. “The more we know, the better we are able to understand the Ancients - but also our current galaxy.”

“Do you tell your students that to motivate them to sift through tons of sand, Professor?” Jack smirked.

His friend pouted. “I don’t have students. I merely give a few lectures on occasion. And I am not a professor.”

Jack knew that. “You give lectures at universities. So, you’re a professor.”

“That’s not how it works! It’s…”

“Anyway,” Jack interrupted him as Entrapta and Carter, followed by Teal’c and Bra’tac, arrived. “Close the gate and get ready - we’ve got a tribute delegation to ambush!”

“From Khalid, Apophis’s poorest and least important vassal,” Catra said. “I bet even Apophis has forgotten about the guy.”

“Oh, I doubt that.” Jack snorted. “Apophis is the kind of petty snake that will absolutely notice if even a single grain isn’t delivered as ordered.” Even though, according to the Tok’ra intel, Apophis hadn’t personally met Khalid’s delegation in decades. That was why they were going to use them as a cover, after all.

“Yes,” Daniel agreed. “He’s petty and cruel - and greedy.”

“And arrogant,” Glimmer added as the wormhole collapsed. “Everyone who has met him agrees on that.”

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded.

“Oh, yes.” Jack nodded as well. He looked around. The place was flat, with no cover or concealment available. Under normal circumstances, that would be a bad spot for an ambush. But since their targets would be arriving through the Stargate, expecting to be on Saqqara thanks to the Tok’ra, their surprise should be enough. It wasn’t as if they could retreat through the Stargate, anyway. Not while it was active.

“Everyone knows the plan?” Jack asked. He didn’t wait for an answer before continuing: “Take them down as soon as they walk through the gate and drag them off the ramp. Don’t damage or dirty their uniforms and armour too much - we need them.”

“Yes, we know. It’s not the most complex plan we’ve ever seen,” Glimmer said, rolling her eyes.

“I’m ready!” Bow hefted his, well, bow and one of his trick arrows - the one launching a net.

“Alright. Take your positions!” Adora said. “They could arrive any minute!”

Then the waiting began.

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Gate Area, PK-Z642, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“‘Any minute’? It’s been fifteen minutes already. I’m going to take a nap. Wake me up once the gate activates!”

Adora frowned as her lover did as she announced and lay down on top of a rock near the Stargate. “Catra…”

“I’m sleeping.” Catra interrupted her, sprawling with two limbs and her tail hanging off the rock’s sides, her head resting on her lower arm.

Adora crossed her arms. “You’re not asleep.” Not yet - not even Catra managed to fall asleep that fast.

A snore was her answer. Adora could press on, but… Catra could be stubborn. And while this was setting a bad example, there were no soldiers around to get the wrong impression. Everyone - Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta and SG-1 - was already familiar with Catra's antics. Except for Bra'tac, but the old Jaffa seemed amused by the scene.

"No warrior can indefinitely stay ready to fight at a moment's notice," he said. "It just tires them out."

"Although the false gods often ignore that wisdom," Teal'c added.

"Yes, they do. And it has cost them battles and good warriors," Bra'tac agreed. "And once word of the new synthetic symbionts spreads, it might yet cost them even more."

That's why we are doing this - well, part of the reason, Adora thought.

"Let's hope so," Jack said. "We can…"

The sound of the wormhole being formed - a few minutes early! - interrupted him.

"Heads up! Incoming!" he snapped.

Adora stepped up and formed her sword. Catra had already rolled off the rock and drawn her shock rod.

A few seconds later, two men appeared out of the wormhole - Jaffa wearing armour and carrying staff weapons. They gasped, startled, but before they could react, Bow hit them with a net arrow that entangled both.

Adora was already moving, slapping their staffs out of their hands and pushing them off the ramp. They flew a few yards and landed in the sand, rolling a few more yards, tightly wrapped in the net.

Another Jaffa appeared, but Catra tackled him off the ramp as well, tearing his helmet off and stunning him with her shock rod

before they hit the ground. That would be the leader of the delegation.

Then a wagon came through the gate - the tribute for Apophis, pushed by slaves. They froze at the sight.

“Get off the ramp! Leave the wagon!” Jack snapped, gesturing to the side. They hastily did so, huddling together at the foot of the ramp.

Between Adora, Teal’c and Bra’tac, the two Jaffa bringing up the rear were quickly taken care of as well. The wormhole collapsed shortly after they, too, were in the sand next to the ramp.

Catra grabbed the still-twitching leader. “Alright! Let’s strip them!”

That didn’t take long, either. Though Daniel had to explain to the slaves that they wouldn’t be killed but set free. And to the Jaffa that they were now prisoners, but that didn’t go over as well - their leader was still threatening them with ‘the Great Khalid’s revenge’ as they pushed him through the gate back to Earth. It wasn’t very impressive, even if he hadn’t been in his underwear.

Glimmer eyed the robes the slaves had been wearing with obvious distaste as she held them up. They were clean, though - Khalid wouldn’t send his delegation, not even the slaves, in dirty clothes to Apophis.

“What? Not sparkly enough?” Catra grinned. “Too bad. You’re too small to pass for a Jaffa.”

Glimmer huffed. “I don’t want to wear the heavy armour anyway.”

“It’s not that heavy, actually,” Bow commented, slipping into the set that fit him best. “And not as constricting as I expected. And you can see quite well in this helmet,” he added in a muffled voice after putting it on.

“What good would it be to design armour that hindered a warrior in combat? Even the false gods would not indulge their vanity that

much," Bra'tac said, changing armour himself.

"Indeed."

Bow was correct, Adora found once she donned her own set. The helmet didn't restrict her vision much. About on par with Horde infantry helmets, actually. And they had a set of armour in She-Ra's size. Fortunately, it wasn't the more ornate set that the leader of the delegation had worn; Adora wouldn't have been able to pull off posing as him.

Bra'tac would do that, with Adora, Teal'c, Bow and Jack posing as his guards, and the rest disguising themselves with the robes from the slaves. The robes were a bit large on some of them, especially Entrapta, but that only served to disguise them better, in Adora's opinion. And the Goa'uld were supposed to ignore slaves anyway. Unless they were looking for hosts or something. But they should be safe enough pushing the wagon.

"It's really weird," Entrapta commented as they dialled the Stargate to Saqqara. "They have the technology. Why didn't they build a self-propelled wagon?"

"Tradition, I think. Paying tribute is a ceremonial event," Daniel explained. "It's more about the show of loyalty than the actual tribute - and that means the optics matter more than efficiency. Having slaves push your old-fashioned tribute wagon sends a message."

"Like a parade," Jack added.

"But according to our data, Apophis doesn't even watch this," Entrapta objected.

Daniel nodded. "Yes, which is also sending a message. To Khalid and Apophis's other vassals."

"Khalid sounds like Apophis's Kyle," Catra muttered as she adjusted her hood.

"What is a Kyle?" Bra'tac asked.

Before they could explain, the wormhole formed.

Adora nodded. It was time. They had people to save.

"Let's go."

*****

Gate Area, Saqqara, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

The contrast to Chulak was striking, Samanha Carter thought after stepping through the wormhole and arriving on Saqqara. Chulak's Stargate was in the open plains, quite far from the capital, and guarded at most by a token force posted there.

Saqqara's Stargate was housed in a bunker. And Apophis had remodelled since Bra'tac and Teal'c had last visited, from the looks of it, with a dozen guards close to the Stargate augmented by more behind embrasures in a new wall that surrounded the entire setup. Apophis didn't take any chances on his homeworld. Though he lacked an iris or other mechanism to block the Stargate… no, she realised as she pushed the heavy tribute wagon forward, the Stargate could be lowered to the ground, blocking it. Of course, if a party was expected, the gate would be open…

The wagon reached the top of the ramp, and Sam and the others next to her pushing it had to switch to pulling back so it wouldn't run down the ramp and smash into the official from Apophis waiting there. Without Catra, they would have had to struggle, but as things were, it didn't take too much of an effort to slowly guide the wagon downwards.

That also meant Sam could focus on other things more easily. Such as taking in the layout of the room and the position of the guards watching them. They were set up for a crossfire, positioned in a quarter-circle so they wouldn't hit each other. Like at Stargate Command. And they were watching everyone, including the 'slaves', with their staff weapons ready. Good troops.

"...and here is the tribute of Khalid the Great for the magnificent Apophis! Treasure from his domain, jewellery wrought by the best smiths in his realm! The finest Dakir pelts, unique in the entire Galaxy! And salted Qu'adu fit for the most refined palate of the magnificent Apophis, may his reign last eternally!" Bra'tac gestured at the wagon as Daniel, Glimmer, Entrapta, Sam and Catra took a step back from it, bowing low.

The pompous official - not a Jaffa, a Goa'uld, Sam noted - sniffed rather derisively. "Yes, yes, the usual." He nodded at two Serpent Guards standing behind him. "Search it."

The two approached the wagon, pulled the covers away and started inspecting the various items and crates there. They were used to this, Sam noted - they moved and acted like customs officials at international airports. But a physical inspection wouldn't detect everything, and Apophis was no fool, so…

She kept her head lowered so the hood would hide her face but glanced around. There, on a raised balcony, another Jaffa stood behind a console. That would be the one to use sensors to check for contraband. As Bra'tac had told them. And the scanners she could see looked more advanced than the standard ones they met in the field. A little, at least.

"Nothing," one Jaffa reported.

The Goa'uld snorted at that and checked on his communicator. "And the scan is clean as well. Well, take the tribute to the usual vault." He made a dismissive gesture with his hand and turned away before Bra'tac could reply.

Evidently, Khalid was not held in high esteem. Or any esteem at all. Sam hoped that didn't extend to his servants and slaves being fair game for anyone higher up the food chain. The predictable response to any such attempt would complicate their mission.

Bra'tac huffed - softly, though - and gestured at the rest of their group. "Move! We fulfil our duty!"

Sam started pushing again, and they moved forward. The massive gate in front of them started to open, revealing walls fit for a vault, not merely a bunker. So, a gate room, surrounded by fortified firing positions, all inside a vault. And deep underground - a lift was waiting for them. Apophis took his gate security very seriously.

But not seriously enough to simply have the tribute handed over to his own guards in the gate room and Khalid's delegation sent home from there. Because, Sam thought as the lift stopped and the doors opened, he wants his visitors to see the glory of his capital.

Before them, a maze of buildings sprawled - stone and fake stone, Sam guessed - all massive, built in a vaguely Egyptian style. She could see factory complexes in the back. And all of them were dwarfed by the colossal, roughly pyramid-shaped palace of Apophis in the distance. Death Gliders roamed the sky above it in pairs, probably more for show than for actual patrolling. Jaffa guards lined the wide avenue leading to the palace. Their destination.

"And we have to push the damn wagon all the way to the palace…" Sam heard Catra mutter next to her. "I should have insisted on being a guard."

"Move!" Bra'tac snapped.

They started pushing.

"Architecture meant to impress," Daniel noted. "Some dictators back on Earth did the same. Or attempted to. Any visitor will march through the very heart of Apophis's power."

It was impressive, Sam had to admit. As they walked past the buildings, she could see hundreds, thousands of people moving between them, through side streets and on bridges and passages spanning between buildings. It was a stark contrast to the typical worlds under Goa'uld control.

Yet, she added silently, after making a few calculations, it still didn't come close to the metropolises on Earth. Or their factories. But this was only one of the Goa'uld Empire's core worlds.

*****

Apophis has to be compensating for a lot, Catra thought as they approached the Goa'uld's palace. The pyramid was even bigger than Bright Moon - the city, not the palace. And the street leading to it was wide enough for an entire hovertank platoon to travel side by side. Good ambush spots in the buildings lining the road, of course, but still - not the best arrangement from a defensible point of view.

Of course, if the Alliance had to attack the palace, they'd do with orbital and air bombardment and probably drop infantry and bots straight on the remains instead of launching a ground campaign. Much easier on the civilians as well. But if Catra would have to do a ground assault, she'd still send a unit straight down the road, if only to trip all the ambushers and traps. A group of bots would be perfect for that. Meanwhile, the main forces would strike at the exposed ambushers and push on - and also attack from the flank and make their own approaches by levelling some buildings. Hovertanks could fly over rubble, and the bots could climb over it.

But if she was limited to Earth ground troops… Yeah, assaulting the city would be a meat grinder for everyone. She'd better use assault shuttles to take the palace from the air. Though the air defences would have to be taken out first - even shielded shuttles could only take so much fire. And that meant they would have to lure the enemy forces into revealing themselves. Which meant Horde fighters piloted by bots as bait.

No matter how she looked at it, it would be a costly battle. And the cost would be even worse for Apophis's forces. Maybe it would be better to just level the palace from orbit, wreck the factories and barracks, and then wait the survivors out? Judging by how nice the air smelt, Apophis's factory complexes were either much cleaner than Horde ones - she doubted that - or he had a lot less

capacity around his palace than Hordak had had in the Fright Zone during the war.

Apophis himself was another problem for any assault, of course. The snake could, in the face of certain defeat, take over any servant and hide amongst his slaves. And he wouldn't be the only Goauld doing that. Sorting out the hosts from the rest would be a nightmare. They'd need a decapitation strike to prevent that, but that was a lot harder to pull off than a simple invasion with superior forces. And probably best done with stealth shuttles again.

Catra narrowed her eyes, wishing she could throw off the damn hood and let her ears move freely. And kick off - and shred with her claws - the stupid boots she was wearing. She shouldn't have to wear boots unless the environment called for it. And this planet wasn't too cold or too hot.

Anyway, decapitation strikes were a good idea, but with the genetic memory of the snakes and the whole religious indoctrination of their forces and slaves, even taking out Apophis wouldn't really end the battle. But it would fragment his forces, which would make it far easier to defeat them in detail or catch them on the move. Earth armoured forces would be quite effective for that.

They were now two-thirds to the palace. And she had to control herself every step not to unsheath her foot claws for better traction. She really should have insisted on posing as a Jaffa guard. Sure, she was a bit small for a Jaffa, but unlike humans, she had the strength for it. Have O'Neill pose as a slave pushing a damn wagon like a horse. Or get Swift Wind to pull it. Make the damn horse be useful for a change. Heh, a winged horse as a gift would get them an audience with Apophis, allowing them to take him out…

They were passing the massive shield generators - well, the shield projectors on the surface - that were guarding the palace. Those would have to be reduced from orbit, of course. Or sabotaged

before the assault. Breaking through on the ground would take a lot of firepower, though it wasn't impossible, as the Battle of Bright Moon had shown.

Inside the perimeter of the palace, though not yet inside the palace itself, she could spot far more guards than in the city. Enough to cover all approaches - not that that was hard; there was a strip surrounding the pyramid that had been cleared of any cover.

And now came the hardest part: Pushing the stupid wagon up the slope to the palace gates without losing her temper or losing her disguise. Grunting, she adjusted to the increased effort. If anyone ever made a draft animal joke about this…

"It's so inefficient…" Entrapta complained under her breath. "A single bot could have drawn the entire wagon. Somebody should have told Apophis that long ago!"

Catra snorted. Having slaves struggle was the point. Like in cadet training. Well, there, it was to foster team unity or something through shared hardship, though, for some instructors, that was just an excuse.

With another grunt, she pushed the wagon to the top of the slope, right in front of the palace gates.

Finally! They had arrived!

Now all they had to do was to vanish somewhere between the gate and the vaults, find Teal'c's family and Daniel's wife, kill Apophis if he was around, and leave.

After pushing the tribute wagon all the way here? Piece of cake.

*****

Palace of Apophis, Saqqara, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

You'd think Apophis had a subscription to 'Dictator's Quarterly', Jack O'Neill thought as they entered the palace. Most of the decor would fit perfectly in any of the palaces of various 'great leaders' and other rich and powerful scumbags on Earth that he had studied during his career for missions that had never happened, and a few that *definitely* had never happened, no sir. Massive marble columns, wall reliefs with gold inlays, carved wooden and ivory - or something alien that looked like it - furniture littered the hallways and rooms wherever you looked.

Of course, they were walking to the tribute vault, so this would be a route where Apophis's underlings would have taken extra care to impress any visitors. The whole palace wouldn't be full of such expensive gaucheness, or whatever you called it. On the other hand, Apophis had had a few thousand years to decorate and so many worlds to plunder…

He kept looking around as they walked down a big hallway. The armour was alright, but the helmet was a pain in the ass. It restricted his field of vision just a little bit, but it was enough to be noticeable and make him keep moving his head to cover his blindspots. Maybe he should have posed as a slave instead. But then he wouldn't be armed, and that would feel even worse than wearing a stupid helmet.

They passed another pair of guards standing to the sides - the fifth on the route - and finally reached the big lift to the vaults. A red light flickered over them - some scanner, Jack was sure. But unless Apophis had suddenly rediscovered magic or turned the lift into some X-ray machine, the scanner wouldn't find anything amiss. The 'slaves' were not carrying anything unusual. The 'guards' were armed with two zats and a staff weapon, but that wasn't too unusual. And Bra'tac was carrying Entrapta's multitool, but she had assured them that no known Goa'uld technology would identify its magic parts. Or the other parts hidden in the staff weapons.

Would be a hell of a time to discover that the princess had been wrong, of course.

The lift doors opened without any alert being sounded, and Bra'tac motioned to the others to push the wagon inside, but that didn't mean anything. If Jack were in charge, he'd turn the lift into a trap for intruders. It was the perfect ambush spot.

But once again, no alert sounded, and the lift slowly descended without any trouble until it opened again into a hallway made of metal - Naquadah-enhanced steel; Jack recognised the shine. Apophis didn't joke around when it came to his treasure chamber.

He also had four Jaffa guards here, plus another snake flunky, and probably a dozen more behind one of the side doors.

"Halt!" the flunky said. "This is the tribute?"

Jack pressed his lips together before he could make a quip about having mixed up the tribute with the cargo for the recycling plant back home. What did the snake expect? That somehow the guards at the Stargate and the ones at the palace entrance had made a mistake?

"Yes," Bra'tac replied. "The Great Khalid has sent the finest treasure to…"

"The finest treasures of your master are barely fit to enter these vaults," the Goa'uld interrupted him. He inspected the wagon with a sneer. "Quadu? Are stupid? That's for the kitchen, not the vault!"

The snake still grabbed one of the things and snacked on it, Jack noted, before turning to the guards. "Take the rest inside and those bags to the kitchen!"

And now comes the dismissal, Jack thought. Petty flunkies like that snake always jumped at the opportunity to lord it over someone else.

"What are you still doing here?" The Goa'uld scoffed. "Return to your master!"

Bra'tac bowed his head, then turned around. "We have done our duty! We will return to the Great Khalid!"

They went back into the lift. Jack glanced around. They were under observation - the camera in the ceiling was not subtle at all. But they had expected that. And they had timed the lift's route on the way down.

As soon as the doors closed, Bra'tac slapped the tool into Entrapta's hands. "Don't break it!" he snarled, then gripped his staff with both hands, acting as if he was angry at the insults thrown his way by pretty much everyone. Well, maybe he was angry.

Jack didn't care as long as their plan worked. And that depended on Entrapta and Carter, who were huddling over the tool. And taking their time - they were already halfway to the top. Maybe closer.

Jack clenched his teeth. Carter and her buddy wouldn't let them down. He had to trust them.

"We did it!" Entrapta announced.

"We hacked the cameras, sir," Carter reported. "And we found a hiding spot."

"Great!" Jack grinned.

They reached the ground floor and stepped out of the lift. Vanishing inside it would have been a bit too risky. The guards would wonder why an empty lift arrived. But disappearing on the way out? Plenty of crossings to duck into. Especially if you controlled the cameras and knew the blind spots of the guards.

Halfway to the gate, they darted to the side and dashed down a small maintenance corridor - still shiny with all the gold you could muster - and into a storage room or whatever the snake used it for.

“Alright!” Jack said as he handed his staff weapon over to Carter, then pulled his spare zat out while she started disassembling it. “Let’s get this show on the road!”

*****

Adora watched the door while Sam, Entrapta and Bow quickly took apart the three fake staff weapons they had brought and started building - no, assembling - the tools they needed for this. And Bow’s ‘Q Bow’, as Jack had dubbed the contraption Bow had somehow managed to slide into the hollowed-out shaft of a staff. A reference to James Bond, Daniel had told them, before explaing that James Bond was a fictional British spy usually doing the same missions they were now doing. Which was a good omen, or should be one, in Adora’s opinion.

“Alright! With the computers linked and the programs loaded, we just need to adapt them to the latest data, and we can go hack the entire security system!” Entrapta announced, beaming from behind the rather fragile-looking array of bits and pieces spread out on the chest-turned-table in the middle of the storeroom.

“I’m almost done with the connection to the main data line here!” Bow was hanging upside down from the ceiling, next to Catra, who had sliced open the stone with her claws to expose the cables. One of Bow’s tools dropped when he shifted, but Catra grabbed it before it hit the ground.

“Careful.”

“Thanks.”

“I am adapting our algorithms,” Sam said, not looking up from her ‘improvised holographic laptop’, as Entrapta had called it. Even with both the screen and the keyboard replaced by holoprojections, the components for that alone had taken an entire staff weapon to conceal, as Bow had explained to Adora. The others had been mostly used to smuggle the explosives Jack had wanted and Bow’s bow.

That left them with two working staff weapons for Teal'c and Bra'tac and ten zats for everyone else. And Adora's sword, Bow's new bow - though he only had a few arrows for it - and Glimmer's staff, but that was literally just a weighted shaft of a staff weapon.

"Done," Sam said. "We can now begin our intrusion into Apophis's system."

"Great. Let's find our missing family members and get out," Jack said. "Wouldn't want to overstay our welcome."

"Visiting delegations often enjoyed some time in the taverns of the capital," Teal'c commented. "They will not expect us to return immediately."

"Although Khalid's delegations are not known to mingle as much as others," Bra'tac added, "since they are held in derision by the Serpent Guard and other vassals. Still, few of them would forego the opportunity to enjoy the amenities that a much more advanced planet than their master's holdings can offer."

"Meaning, we have some time until someone starts looking for us," Catra said, dropping from the ceiling and landing lightly on all four after flipping in midfall. She straightened and sniffed the air. "But don't take too long, anyway."

Adora nodded in agreement.

"We can do it quickly, or we can do it safely. Relatively safely," Bow retorted.

"Let's do it safely!" Daniel cut in. He looked nervous, gripping his zat tightly in his hand.

Of course, he would be nervous, Adora berated herself. Sha're might be in the palace.

"Yeah. We can go quickly later - we probably will have to go quickly, very quickly then." Jack nodded.

It was a very weak joke, and gallows humour, as they called it on Earth, but everyone chuckled at it.

And then came the worst part of any mission, in Adora's opinion - waiting while others worked. She hated this. She wanted to help them. Make herself be useful. Do anything.

But she couldn't do anything here. She couldn't help with the hacking - and even if she had the skills, the others were already crowded around both the one computer they had managed to smuggle in and Entrapta's tool. She couldn't even fetch some food or something - they were in a storeroom, not the palace or headquarters.

She gritted her teeth and sighed.

"Stop that," Catra whispered to her.

"Stop what?" Adora whispered back.

"Fretting and feeling useless."

"I wasn't…" Adora trailed off with a pout as Catra snickered. But then she narrowed her eyes. Catra's tail was twitching, and that meant… "Stop fretting yourself," Adora told her. Her lover wasn't doing any better! Well, she should have realised that at once - Catra wasn't the most patient person.

Catra scoffed in return but didn't deny it.

At least Glimmer was holding up better. Then again, she was watching Bow working, so that was kind of cheating. So…

"Look at that!" Entrapta exclaimed.

"Ah, yes. Let's check the records." Sam's fingers flew over… well, the table, passing through the projected keyboard.

"And the feeds from the cameras - can we run a quick search?" Bow added.

“We would have to free some computing power, but… I think so. The system is not quite as advanced as Horde Prime’s.” Entrapta nodded. “So… Oh! Another hit?”

“But not the same location. Oh. Different people.”

Adora clenched her teeth. She wanted to ask what was going on, but she didn’t want to bother her friends in the middle of this critical task.

“I’ve got confirmation! Look at that!”

Adoa cocked her head to look at the projected display. There were multiple pictures there, camera feeds, it seemed, slightly grainy, but…

“Drey’auc. Ryla’c,” Teal’c whispered.

“They’re in the palace dungeons. As expected,” Sam confirmed. “But…”

“Sha’re.” Daniel was staring at another picture. And that camera didn’t show a dungeon cell.

“Yes. She’s in the women’s quarters of the palace,” Sam said.

“We have to save her!” Daniel blurted out, looking at Jack - and then at Adora. “All of them,” he added a moment later.

Adora nodded. “That’s why we’re here,” she reassured him.

The only question was how. According to their data, the dungeons were not even near the women’s quarter. Those were close to Apophis’s personal quarters, in the upper part of the palace. If anything went wrong, if the alarm was raised, it would quickly become impossible to reach the other location.

“We’ll have to split up,” Catra said, looking at the holoprojection.

*****

The Rescue Operation Part 2

Palace of Apophis, Saqqara, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We have to split up."

"Never split the party," the Colonel replied at once. "Don't tell me you never played Dungeons and Dragons!"

Samantha Carter refrained from rolling her eyes.

"Actually, we still have to play a game," Bow said. "I have a character and a mini ready, but we never seem to get around to setting up a session."

"With good reason, Bow." Catra did roll her eyes. "Seriously, we have to split up. Do you think we can sneak into Apophis's harem with Teal'c's family in tow?"

"You want to sneak into his harem?" Adora asked.

"You want to blast your way inside?" Catra retorted. "Give them time to retreat?"

"And endanger all the other people there," Sam added.

"Yeah, that too." Catra nodded while Adora frowned.

"We could go through the air ducts!" Entrapta suggested. "Like before."

"If it works." Catra shrugged.

Sam nodded in agreement. "Such a huge building has to have extensive air ducts to ensure it remains habitable."

"It might take time to circumvent the various filters and sensors, though," Bow pointed out.

"Yes. Apophis has a layered security system. The most important areas are guarded much more tightly than the rest of his palace," Bra'tac said.

"Well, spend too much on the glitz to impress the neighbours, and you end up not having enough to keep your home safe." The Colonel shrugged. "Couldn't happen to a nicer guy."

"But we don't have unlimited time," Adora said. "And if we're in the air ducts, we can't move fast and are vulnerable if anything happens. Most of us won't be able to do anything while Entrapta, Sam and Bow deal with the security."

That was correct as well. The longer they took, the higher the chances that someone would notice that they had never left the palace. And while she wasn't claustrophobic, Sam would prefer not to be stuck in an air duct during a battle. She grimaced at the thought of being helpless like that.

"It's not as if we can just walk into Apophis's harem or dungeons," the Colonel explained. "I doubt he gives tours to Khalid's finest."

"Then we'll have to change disguises," Glimmer said. "Find a disguise that will allow us to access the dungeons and the harem."

"We can check our data for that!" Entrapta cheered, and her hair flew over their holographic keyboard.

Sam pressed her lips together. She had a decent idea of what they would find based on their past experience. And she knew she would loathe it.

But it was probably the best way to rescue Sha're and Teal'c's family.

Sighing, she joined her friend.

*****

“So… standard guards in the dungeons,” the Colonel said five minutes later. “All we need to do is catch a shift change, get their armour, and walk inside.”

“And fight off the guards in the dungeons,” Daniel added. “Without triggering an alert.”

“Timing will be critical. We have to enter both locations at the same time, or close to it,” Catra said. “That will be tricky.”

“But not impossible. Apophis’s Serpent Guard follow a strict schedule - which we know thanks to your efforts.” Teal’c nodded at Sam and Entrapta.

“And they work in squads of four,” Sam pointed out. They had more than that.

“We could pass one of us as a prisoner to be processed,” Teal’c suggested, “if you can insert a fake order of such a transfer into the system. They will not check such an order with their superior, unlike an order to release a prisoner.”

And there went Sam’s alternative plan.

“Someone’s been watching a New Hope again.” The Colonel grinned. “Well, it worked on the Empire’s cells.”

“It ended with the whole team being crushed in a trash compactor,” Daniel said.

“I doubt Apophis has such a thing here.”

“That leaves the harem. The only ones getting in and out are servants,” Catra said.

Female servants chosen for their looks, Sam knew. And they were dressed to show that. She could hide some tools even so, but a zat would be difficult already. And if the Colonel made a joke about this…

“Well, that will work for you,” Catra said. “He has a small army of human slaves. But I think I would stick out a bit if I tried to pass as a servant in those clothes.” She narrowed her eyes. “And don’t even joke about shaving my fur!”

“Oh, I wasn’t thinking about that,” Glimmer said with a grin that belied her words. “Instead, I was thinking we should use that you will stick out.”

“What do you mean?” Catra blinked. “Oh, right.” She grinned. “That could work.”

“What?” Adora asked.

“We present her as a gift from a vassal - maybe Khalid,” Glimmer said.

“And you can bet that Apophis’s favourite will personally come to check me out,” Catra added. “Saves us the time to try and find her in the harem.”

“Oh, right.” Adora nodded. “And they won’t suspect anything if they don’t recognise us.”

“But Apophis might hear about that as well and come inspect his gift,” Daniel pointed out.

“Even better.” Catra grinned and flashed her claws. “Two rats with one swipe.”

“And we can use one of you as our guide,” Glimmer said, looking at Bow.

“Preferably one who knows the palace and the Serpent Guard’s drill,” Sam said.

“Right,” Bow agreed.

“I shall come with you, then,” Bra’tac said. “You, my friend, go free your family.”

"Indeed."

*****

Catra wasn't a prude. She had grown up as a Horde cadet in the barracks, with a shared shower and bunk room. But wearing what felt like a few strips of silk, liberated from a store room they had found a bit deeper into the palace, tied around her chest and waist, still felt a bit uncomfortable. Differently uncomfortable than the gold jewellery that Bar'tac had had with him - apparently, he used that to trade for supplies on Chulak. Fine metal rings and chains didn't go well with fur such as hers. Still, she could handle either easily.

But posing as a gift from an underling for his Lord, dressing to attract Apophis's attention? Catra wouldn't mind drawing attention, but the implications of what kind of attention she would catch were a little bit disturbing.

Not that she'd complain about that, of course. She could handle slight discomfort. And it wasn't as if anything actually would happen - if Apophis turned out to be home, she would cut him apart with her claws at the first opportunity. Too bad about his host, but taking out Apophis was worth it, and she couldn't hide a zat or shock rod like this.

She glanced at the others. Adora looked… Well, she was wearing about the same amount of silk fabric as Catra was, but on She-Ra's body.

"I think I should change," Catra's lover complained, tugging at the strips crossing her chest. "I'm sticking out a bit too much like this."

"And if you have to change into She-Ra in front of witnesses?" Glimmer shook her head. "It's safer this way."

'If'? More like 'when', Catra thought. The odds of Glimmer's plan working without a hitch were… Well, she wouldn't bet a *brown* Horde ration bar on it. "We want to draw attention, remember?"

she reminded Adora. “You’re not supposed to fade into the background.”

Adora nodded with a pout.

Catra snorted when she caught her lover trying to hide how she pulled on her clothes again. “Anyway, are we ready?”

Glimmer nodded. “Yes.” She looked determined. Of course, it was her plan, so she couldn’t complain about it.

Sam also nodded. “Yes.” She didn’t seem to be happy either, but that was understandable.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded eagerly. She probably thought this was a great opportunity to gather more data about the Goa’uld.

“And remember,” Glimmer told her, “Don’t use your hair.”

“I’ll remember!” Said hair formed a thumbs-up gesture. From anyone else, that would have been a snarky gesture.

“Then I believe we should move,” Bra’tac said, pulling on his newly acquired Serpent Guard helmet.

“Good. And remember: The Alliance doesn’t kill prisoners,” Glimmer told him.

Catra rolled her eyes. They should have told Bra’tac that before he had used his zat to kill and disintegrate the former owner of his new armour. How could he have known about this policy?

Bra’tac, though, merely nodded. “I shall.”

Catra suspected that meant Bra’tac wouldn’t take any prisoners from now on and simply kill his enemies. On the other hand, he would know best that not everyone working for Apophis was actually a willing enemy.

Whatever. They were here to save Sha’re, not everyone else. “Let’s go.”

Bra’tac nodded and led them out of the room.

They didn’t encounter many on the way to the harem - only one patrol of four Serpent Guards who were easily fooled by Bra’tac and a handful of slaves. For the size of the Palace, it housed surprisingly few people. Apophis probably thought that showed off his might or something, but it was a serious security risk, in Catra’s opinion, if intruders could pretty much walk in the open without anyone seeing them - once the cameras had been hacked, of course. Although Apophis’s cybersecurity, as Sam called it, wasn’t exactly great either.

But now they were reaching the entrance to Apophis’s private quarters - of which the women’s quarters were a part. And the guards here were sharp. They still stared at Catra, like the others on the way, but she had a feeling that they were sizing her up as a potential threat as much as they were sizing her up. She did her best to look harmless. Like one of the silly catgirls from those Earth animations the Japanese made.

“I bring a gift from Khalid for Apophis!” Bra’tac announced. “An exotic concubine!” He gestured at Catra, who bowed her head in return. Her ears twitched, and her tail swished back and forth. This was it. If the guards checked with the Stargate room or the palace gates, then they would not only have to fight their way into the harem but also find and capture Sha’re before the Goa’uld possessing her could escape.

“A Sekhmet?” the commander of the guards asked.

Catra suppressed the urge to scowl.

“No.” Bra’tac shook his head. “A species of near-humans from a distant planet, according to Khalid's delegation.”

“An unknown world?”

“I would not dare speculate what the mighty Apophis knows,” Bra’tac replied. “But it was unknown to the Great Khalid.” He sneered at the title.

Catra’s ears caught two of the guards softly snorting in their helmets. Good. If they underestimated them, this would be easier.

“Should I take them back?”

“No.” The commander shook his head. He turned to look at the two closest guards. “Let them in.”

Bra’tac bowed, stepping to the side while the doors - thick, armoured gates - swung open.

And then the commander flicked his hand at them, and Catra and the others entered Apophis’s quarters.

So far, so good.

*****

It is a good thing, Jack O’Neill thought as they approached the dungeons, that the prison guards aren’t picked from the Serpent Guards’ elite. Between the four of them disguised as Jaffa, they had trouble marching perfectly in step with each other. Daniel wasn’t a soldier to begin with, Bow apparently never had done formation drills in the Princess Alliance, being ‘assigned’ by Glimmer to herself from the start, and while Jack and Teal’c had done the drills, the Air Force and the Serpent Guard had different marching cadences.

Still, while Jack would never let it go, it should be good enough for a prison guard duty squad. According to both Bra’tac and Teal’c, that wasn’t a high-prestige posting and was generally left to newer recruits. Unless there was a dangerous prisoner that rated special attention, of course. Such as Bra’tac, Teal’c or SG-1.

Teal’c’s family shouldn’t be in that league. But they were adjacent, sort of. And it was possible that this was a trap for a rescue

operation. So far, things had gone a bit too smoothly for Jack's taste. Judging by past experiences, something should have gone wrong by now, and SG-1 should have been scrambling to improvise. Sure, the security at the palace was pretty much like Bra'tac and Teal'c had said it would be, though the Stargate's security had been improved. But shouldn't Apophis have made more changes after both his last two Primes had defected? Tyrants like him were on the paranoid side.

On the other hand, deliberately weakening his palace's security to ambush a rescue team also didn't sound like something Apophis would do. He had to be wary of assassination attempts and coups by rival System Lords and ambitious underlings. That was what life was like when you were the top snake in your snake pit. Couldn't happen to a nicer guy.

They turned the last corner of the hallway and saw the entrance to the dungeons ahead of them. Four Jaffa stood at attention - just as they had seen on the cameras. They stood straight, with no sign of tiring, but standing straight and not showing weakness was pretty much beaten into Jaffa from their earliest childhood, so that didn't tell Jack anything about their quality as soldiers.

"Halt!" their leader bellowed, holding out his hand. "State your business."

The rest of the group didn't move an inch, just one standing a tiny bit straighter, Jack noticed. Wouldn't elite Jaffa warriors shift around a little, just in case a group of newcomers turned out to be hostile?

"We are to relieve the third guard shift," Teal'c replied.

"They are not scheduled to be relieved until later," the Jaffa retorted.

"I am aware of that," Teal'c told him. "But the orders we received were clear." He moved his shoulders slightly, not quite shrugging.

“A change of orders?” The Jaffa leader had to be scowling in his helmet as he checked his communicator. “Indeed, there is the order for the shift change. Ordered by…” He trailed off.

Ordered by Apophis himself, as the logs would show. That would keep the Jaffa from looking into the whole change. You didn’t question your almighty god no matter what they did.

“Why wasn’t I informed?” the Jaffa grumbled.

“I cannot say.” Teal’c tilted his head. “Maybe the guards we are to relieve are meant to be sent somewhere else?”

The leader scoffed. “Hopefully to Bre’stec. They deserve it.”

Teal’c chuckled at that, so it must have been a joke.

“Do your duty, then.” The Jaffa nodded at the guard to his left, who stepped aside to speak into a small mic mounted on the wall next to the door.

After a brief exchange, the door slid open, and the rest of the guards moved to let them through.

Inside, eight more Jaffa were waiting. Four were in full armour, standing guard. Another four were sitting at a table, fiddling with their weapons - doing maintenance, if a superior asked, Jack would bet - next to a bunch of glasses and one fancy bottle. One of them stared at Teal’c with narrowed eyes. “What do you want?”

“We were ordered to relieve the third shift,” Teal’c repeated himself. “New orders. From the mighty Apophis himself.”

“What?” The guy jerked and quickly got up to check the console at the other side of the room, almost pushing the guard there out of the way. A few seconds later, he stood straighter. “I see.”

“We are to be relieved?” the armoured Jaffa next to him asked.

“Yes. You are to wait for further orders in your quarters.”

“We hear and obey.” The other Jaffa sounded wary. Few soldiers ever complained about getting a break from guard duties, but new, vague orders were never a good sign.

While the four Jaffa marched out, the apparent Jaffa in charge scowled at Teal’c. “Take over their duties.”

Teal’c bowed, then turned to Jack and the others. “Take up your positions.”

Teal’c knew how the system worked, so he’d stay at the console. Jack moved to guard the door to the cell tract proper, leaving Daniel and Bow to stand at the exit. Good positions to catch the other guards by surprise. He peered through the window in the door behind him. The hallway lined with cell doors was empty.

They already knew in which cells Teal’c’s wife and son were held, so now they just had to wait for the signal from the other group that they had found Sha’re. Or for the alert being raised. Or for something to blow up.

Jack was betting on the last one.

*****

Adora straightened as they left Bra’tac behind and entered Apophis’s personal quarters. Focus on the mission, she told herself. She had done this before, when she had boarded Horde Prime’s flagship to save Catra. But she had been wearing more clothes back then. And she had arrived openly, demanding to be led to Horde Prime after Darla had smashed through the outer hull of the Velvet Glove. She hadn’t sneaked in in disguise. Although her friends had sneaked in.

Like back then, a group of guards faced her, though they were tall, armoured Jaffa instead of tall clones. Their leader looked Adora and her friends over, especially Catra, then nodded. “Follow me.” He turned without waiting for a response or just an acknowledgement.

Apophis's personal quarters were decorated even more opulently than the rest of his palace. So much gold - on the walls, inlaid in furniture, as decor… like Horde Prime, the Goa'uld had stuck to his style all the way through. Though most of the palaces of her friends had a theme as well, she reminded herself. Just nothing so… oppressively blatant?

The slaves they saw on the way to the women's quarters - the harem - were wearing more expensive clothes than the ones outside. Mainly because a lot of what they wore was golden jewellery, far more than Adora and the others were wearing.

She still felt self-conscious about her own skimpy clothes. And she was sure that the others felt the same. Well, not Entrapta - her friend was looking around with a big smile, taking in every detail.

Focus on the mission! Adora told herself. They were here to save Sha're. And take out Apophis if he was around - they hadn't found him on the cameras, but those didn't cover his private personal quarters. He probably didn't want anyone, not even the most loyal guards, to watch him when he slept. Or did other things.

But that would just make it easier to take him out. It would take Adora just a moment to summon her sword - and her suit - and deal with him.

They reached another big door with guards in front of it. That would be the entrance to Apophis's harem. The guards here didn't question the Jaffa leading them - they just stepped aside and opened the doors. It was a nice change for once.

The harem itself didn't look very different compared to the outside quarters. Maybe a few more silk tapestries and curtains lining the walls. And no guards, male or female - the one who had led them there stayed outside as well.

But she could see many women, all of them looking at them and whispering as soon as the doors closed behind Adora and the others.

“No, I am not a Sekhmet!” Catra announced, taking a step forward. “I’m a different species.” She glared at a few - her ears must have picked up their whispers - and the women shrunk away.

“Then what are you?” a Goa’uld’s voice rang out.

Adora turned her head as the women surrounding them parted, bowing their heads, and revealed a slender figure walking towards them, trailed by four slaves. Sha’re. No, it was Amaunet, Adora reminded herself - the Go’auld controlling her body. Apophis’s queen.

Catra met the Goauld’s eyes with a cocky grin. “I am a cat.”

Adora pressed her lips together. Catra was… being Catra. Jack would say cattish.

Amaunet sniffed and stepped closer to Adora’s lover, making a point of looking her over, and Adora clenched her teeth. If the Goa’uld tried whatever…

Catra cocked her head in return, grinning and striking a casual pose - though her tail swishing back and forth ruined it a little. At least for those who knew her, like Adora.

Amaunet narrowed her eyes and walked around Catra. “You are not a Sekhmet, indeed. And not a Furling.” She reached out and grabbed Catra’s tail, then tugged.

Catra hissed and straightened, her ears flattening against her head as she glared over her shoulder at the Goa’uld. “It’s considered very rude to pull a cat’s tail,” she snapped, baring her fangs.

Amaunet scoffed and released it. “Not a hoax, then. Not that Khalid would have dared to try to deceive Apophis with such an obvious plot. But others might have fooled him. Where are you from? Did Nirrti create you?”

Nirrti? Adora remembered the name from a briefing. A Goa'uld geneticist? Or biologist?

Catra shook her head with a sneer. "My species was created by the Ancients. The Gate Builders," she added in a slightly condescending tone.

Typical, Adora thought - Catra just had to try and match the Goa'uld's attitude. She glanced around. They had reached their objective. But they were surrounded by the women in the harem. Some of them might fight Adora and her friends if they attacked Amaunet. And what if Jack and the others hadn't infiltrated the prison yet? Until Entrapta reassembled the communicator hidden in her jewellery, they couldn't check in with them.

"Really? Your species didn't amount to much then if we had never heard of you in the time since the Gate Builders left us." The Goa'uld scoffed again. "Then again, the fact alone that you were acquired by Khalid proves that."

Catra flashed her fangs again in a grin but, surprisingly, didn't say anything to that.

On the other hand, judging by Amaunet's sneer, she didn't have to say anything to keep annoying the Goa'uld. Just being Catra was enough. Well, that wasn't a surprise either.

Amaunet dismissed Cara with a sniff and a gesture - and turned to look at Adora. "And who are you?"

"Adora." Adora bowed her head, then forced herself to stand still while the Goa'uld circled around her.

"You're strong," she heard the woman whisper behind her. "And so tall… Have you ever given birth?" she asked in a louder voice.

What? Adora couldn't help it - she turned to stare at the Goa'uld.

*****

What? Samantha Carter glanced at Amaunet, trying to keep her head down - her disguise wasn't the best, to say the least. The Goa'uld hadn't asked if Adora had a child, just if she had given birth, so it was about her fertility? But why was the Goa'uld interested in that? Goa'uld reproduced asexually by spawning larvae. The way Amaunet stared at Adora - at Adora's body… She must want her as a host, Sam realised.

Adora looked puzzled - and wary. "Why do you want to know that?" she asked.

Amaunet narrowed her eyes, and Sam winced. You didn't talk like that with a Goa'uld queen. Or any Goa'uld if you were a slave.

"Watch your tongue, girl," the Goa'uld snapped. She stepped forward and grabbed Adora's ponytail.

Sam tensed. They were surrounded by civilians, but some of them might be disguised guards. Or just slaves willing to fight and die for their gods. If a fight broke out… had the Colonel and the others reached the cell tract already? Sam hated that they didn't have working comms.

But Adora let the Goa'uld pull her head down, towards Sha're's face. "I am Apophis's queen," the Goa'uld hissed. "Your goddess!"

They stared at each other for a moment before Adora lowered her eyes. Sam didn't think that was enough to placate Amaunet.

"Answer your goddess!" The Goa'uld twisted her fist in Adora's hair. And with her enhanced strength…

"I have not given birth," Adora replied. She was clenching her teeth - but probably not because of pain, Sam suspected.

Amaunet frowned at that.

Was she disappointed? Sam wondered.

"Are you fertile?"

Adora blushed at that. “What?”

“Can you have children?” Amaunet snapped, twisting Adora’s hair further.

“I… think so.” Sam’s friend tensed up.

And Catra’s ears were flattening, her tail swishing back and forth rapidly. Things were about to boil over, Sam realised.

Then the Goa’uld scoffed and released Adora. “We’ll have to test that.”

“What?”

Why did Amaunet want Adora to have children? And with whom? If she desired her as a new host, then the only candidate would be Apophis, but Goa’uld didn’t reproduce with their hosts. It was taboo, according to what Sam knew. Amaunet and Apophis must be planning something. But what?

“You’re about to receive the greatest honour a mortal can hope for - provided your body is fertile,” the Goa’uld declared.

And Sam’s suspicion was confirmed. She glanced at the others. Everyone was tense. Ready. Even though they were still surrounded, this might be the best opportunity…

“Are you looking for a surrogate mother?”

Sam jerked at Entrapta’s question.

Her friend cocked her head at Amaunet. “I mean, it sounds like you want Adora to carry your baby to term if I understood you correctly. I might be wrong, though.”

Sam winced. Entrapta’s curiosity had gotten the better of her. It wasn’t entirely unexpected, too.

The Goa'uld looked puzzled for a moment, then suspicious. "You seem to be quite… educated about this."

"Oh, yes! I've been looking into surrogate motherhood," Entrapta replied cheerfully. "It's a fascinating alternative to more advanced methods when you can't reproduce naturally. Not that it's unnatural, of course!"

Amaunet looked surprised. Sam saw her glance from Entrapta to Adora, to Glimmer and then to Sam. A moment later, the Goa'uld's eyes widened in realisation - or recognition.

"Watch out!" Sam yelled as the woman raised her arm - with a ribbon device!

Catra and Adora launched themselves at Amaunet but crashed into a force field surrounding the Goa'uld.

Then Amaunet used her ribbon device, and Adora was thrown across the room, bowling over a handful of shrieking slaves.

Catra hissed and slashed at the force field, which flickered but held.

Glimmer grabbed a vase before she was tackled by two women from behind.

Before Sam could move to help her, she was attacked herself by a third rushing at her.

Sam stepped to the side and redirected the woman's charge with an Aikido throw, sending her flying into a large vase, which broke under the impact.

Then the alarm sounded, drowning out the shrieks from the fleeing women.

Catra grabbed a heavy wooden bench, but Amaunet hit her with the ribbon device, and she collapsed, screaming as the Goa'uld kept the device going.

"Catra!"

Roaring, Adora charged across the room, sword blazing. One slash shattered the force field. The backswing - with the flat of the blade - knocked Amaunet down, the woman rolling a few yards over the marble floor. She tried to get up, but Adora kicked her in the head and knocked her out.

Sam quickly raced over to relieve the Goa'uld of the ribbon device and her shield generator. If only they had been able to smuggle weapons into the harem! "Check on Catra!" she yelled as she slipped it on. It hadn't been long, but the pain caused by the device would have been excruciating.

Adora quickly took out the last woman fighting with Glimmer while Entrapta moved to Catra, who was groaning and trying to get up. Now that they had Sha're, they had to…

The sound of boots hitting the floor interrupted her thoughts. A moment later, the first Jaffa guard rushed around the corner, staff weapon moving to point at them.

Sam threw herself to the side as the guard fired, and a large, ornate vase vanished in an explosion.

*****

Damn! That hurt! Catra hissed through clenched teeth as she rolled on her front. That snake would pay for…Her eyes widened when she spotted half a dozen - no, more - guards storming into the room, weapons blazing. And her muscles were still shaking!

But before she could force herself to move, she was grabbed and dragged behind an oversized marble bench, just a step ahead of a barrage of staff blasts that blew craters in the wall behind her.

"Catra!" Entrapta gasped as her hair tendrils set Catra down.

"I'm fine!" Catra spat. "We need to move!" Grab Sha're and get out.

“Wait a moment! I need to put the communicator together!” Entrapta replied, crouching down while her hair grabbed the different parts from her jewellery.

“Bra’tac will inform them,” Catra told her friend. The old Jaffa would have noticed the guards charging into the harem even if the alert wasn’t raised in the entire palace. She grabbed Entrapta’s collar and pulled her down when another volley passed overhead.

None hit the bench, though, she realised. Why would…? Ah! They must not want to risk hitting Sha’re with shrapnel from blasts! Wounding or killing Apophis’s queen - or her host - was probably a death sentence. Catra bared her teeth in a grin. “Stay behind cover¨” she snapped and whirled around. She took two, three steps on all fours, her claws digging into the stone floor, then jumped, sailing over the bench in a shallow arc - and landed in the centre, right next to where Glimmer and Sam were dragging away Sha’re while Adora was busy fending off blasts with her sword turned shield to cover them.

“They won’t risk their queen!” Catra hissed as she jumped again, flipping in mid-air and hitting the wall to the side feet first. She pushed off moments before a staff blast hit her spot and pounced on the guard before the staff weapon recycled.

He tried to hit her with it instead, but she twisted around his weapon, her hand claws raking his hands, and then sliced her foot claws into his side, through his chest plate. He screamed and dropped his weapons - and a few fingers, and she went down with it, rolling to the side as two guards turned to engage her.

She dug one set of claws into the floor and spun, her legs sweeping the wounded Jaffa off his feet - and into the line of fire of the others. One staff blast hit his chest and blew through his armour. The other went wide and hit a half-wall, showering a corner with stone fragments. Shrieks sounded from that direction, but Catra ignored them and charged the two Jaffa.

Once more, she was faster than the weapons could cycle, but they knew and fanned out, staffs swinging to catch her no matter where she moved.

But she dug her claws in and stopped in the middle of her charge, then jumped as soon as the staffs passed where she would have been a moment later. One Jaffa kept turning, continuing his staff-swing to hit her, but that exposed his back. Catra kicked the other Jaffa's weapon to the side and raked her claws over the turning guard's back, cutting his spine.

He collapsed with a scream, and she landed on all fours, sliding a step before her claws stopped her. Close enough to cut the staff weapon when the other Jaffa brought it up again.

He stared at the stump of his weapon for a moment, making a surprised sound. Catra didn't need more than that to reach him and ripped his throat out with a swipe of her claws.

She kept going, jumping and rolling to throw off the rest's aim. That left…

A Jaffa flew past her, screaming until he hit the wall and bounced.

Adora was in the middle of the remaining guards. What was left of them, anyway. One Jaffa tried to engage her in melee - and she smashed him with the flat of her blade. Another tried falling back while shooting his staff at her, but he only got off one blast, which she caught with her weapon before she cut him and the staff down.

Another dropped his staff and drew a zat, but Catra disarmed him with a slash of her claws, then cut his throat while he was busy trying to stop the bleeding from his stump.

She ducked behind his corpse and glanced around. The harem women had fled, and Adora had just put down the last guard. But… Her ears twitched. Someone was fighting at the entrance! Bra'tac!

“Grab Sha’re - we need to go!” she yelled. “Bra’tac’s fighting! And grab some weapons!”

Adora whirled.

“Not you! They can handle Sha’re!” Catra snapped and rushed forward. Entrapta alone could probably drag or carry Sha’re with her hair.

Catra dropped to all four to take the corners - easier to avoid slipping on the polished floor. Four guards were standing at the entrance, taking cover behind the open doors and firing at someone outside. Catra threw herself at the closest, her hands slicing into his upper arms as she gripped them and drew her knees to her chest - then pushed down with her feet, claws disembowelling him as she jumped off him and into the next.

Adora took out the third guard, and the fourth had stepped too far out of cover in reaction to their attack, so Bra’tac caught him with a shot in the back.

“Nice shot,” Catra told him, shaking the blood off her claws.

“A raw recruit would not have wasted such an opening,” he retorted, but he was smiling. Not for long. “However, we have a problem,” he went on, growing serious and looking over his shoulder when the others arrived - Glimmer with a staff weapon in hand and zats stuffed in her belt, Sam carrying zats and Entrapta carrying Sha’re and herself with her hair while she was working on their communicator.

“Great,” Catra muttered. “What is it and who do we need to kill to solve it?”

*****

Just as Jack O’Neill was checking - again - if Entrapta had put their communicator together so they could coordinate their strikes, a loud siren filled the room. The other group must have been discovered!

The Jaffa shift leader jumped up and grabbed his helmet. "Enemies are attacking the palace! To arms! Prepare to…"

Teal'c blew his head off with a shot from his staff weapon.

Before the headless corpse dropped to the ground, Jack shot the closest Jaffa at the table with his zat. The guard fell over, toppling his chair. The one next to him dropped as well - but the last one managed to bring his staff weapon to bear, taking cover behind the table.

Jack ducked behind the console - which caught the blast - and when he came up again, Teal'c had already killed the guard.

But the console hadn't survived either. That meant… Jack cursed and whirled towards the door to the cell tract. Locked. And it could only be opened from the console. And the same went for the outer door. They were stuck inside - for now.

Bow checked on the two stunned guards. "This one is dead - we both hit him with our zats," he told Daniel.

"Forget him! Can you hack the door?" Jack asked him.

"Ah…" Bow got up and joined Jack, eyeing the lock. "That will take a while."

And they had to hurry. "Can you shoot a hole into it?" Jack asked Teal'c. He would know the place best.

His friend inclined his head. "It would take a while."

Great. "Time for the all-purpose door opener, then," Jack said, reaching inside his armour for the explosives hidden there. "Guard the entrance. I'll blow it open." There were still guards outside, after all, and though they were locked out for the moment, with the console destroyed, they would have the means to break in once they realised that the prison had been taken over.

Teal’c nodded and aimed his staff at the outer door while Daniel crouched behind the remains of the console and did the same with his zat, and Bow started to put his bow together again.

Jack looked the door over. No hinges to blow up - it slid into the walls to the side. And those were reinforced - he could tell from the way they bulged out. So, no weak points here. “I guess straight through it is,” he mumbled as he started placing the charge. “Never was much for the oblique approach, anyway.”

“Since when?” Daniel commented from his spot nearby.

His friend knew him too well. Jack snorted and armed the detonator before stepping back. “Take cover! This is going to be loud!”

He ducked behind the console next to Daniel, checked with a glance that Bow and Teal’c were clear as well, then hit the remote.

The charges went off, filling the area with smoke, and Jack felt the pressure wave in his chest. As expected.

He got up, zat aimed, and saw that the charge had blown a hole into the door - big enough to wriggle through, even for Teal’c. Not ideal, but it would have to do - he needed the other charges to open the cells themselves.

“Guard the entrance!” he repeated himself and slid through the opening. They had the cameras hacked, but the guards might wonder what was up with that explosion. “If they ask what happened, don’t tell them it’s a reactor leak!”

“I shall not,” Teal’c replied. Jack couldn’t tell if he was amused or not.

It didn’t matter. Once on the other side, Jack quickly moved to Drey’auc’s cell - third from the entrance, on the left. That one was the same model as the one he had just blown through, and Jack placed the charge, then went further ahead to do the same to

Ryal'c's door. "Move away from the doors!" he yelled. He hoped they did.

"Brace yourself!" Jack moved into the guard room again. Then he used the remote again.

Two simultaneous explosions, in a smaller space, were much worse than his first charge - smoke blew through the hole, and he felt the floor shake a little. The guards might have missed the first explosion, but they must have heard this one.

"Get your family," he told Teal'c, aiming his zat at the entrance.

With a curt nod, his friend moved, grunting a little as he had to push himself through the hole in the door. "Drey'auc!" Jack heard him call out. "Ryla'c!"

"Father!"

"Husband."

Neither sounded hurt. Jack was relieved. If they had been at the door when they blew…

"We are here to save you. Come."

Well, that reunion was as touching as Jack should have expected from Teal'c. Then again, the middle of a rescue wasn't the time for romantic moments. Though that bit of common sense wouldn't have stopped Daniel in Teal'c's place.

"Alright," Jack spoke up as Ryal'c and Drey'auc entered the room, coughing slightly from the smoke they had inhaled, followed by Teal'c. "Either the guards outside are deaf, or something is up."

"The walls and doors are thick, but not that thick - I remember hearing screams from inside when I stood guard as a recruit," Teal'c said. "They should have asked what was happening through the intercom, according to our standing orders."

“I guess the standing orders have changed since you and Bra’tac left the Serpent Guard,” Jack said. “Well, if they won’t come to us, we’ll have to go and meet them,” he added, grabbing his last charges.

Half a minute later, another explosion shook the room. But when the smoke cleared, the remains of the door only revealed a metal plate behind it. Heavily armoured, judging by the scratches his bomb had left. “I guess that’s also new,” he said.

“Indeed.”

Damn. Apophis had been a bit smarter than Jack had hoped. They were stuck in here.

*****

The Rescue Operation Part 3

Palace of Apophis, Saqqara, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, Apophis has installed a new layer of security since your defection." Adora nodded at Bra'tac. "Reinforced walls that turned sealed off sections of his private quarters."

"So it would seem. I saw walls go down behind me - fortunately, not between me and you - but the rest is conjecture. If Apophis had meant to limit this to his women's quarter, the walls would have been placed elsewhere," Bra'tac said.

"And we know that the others are trapped in the dungeons," Sam added, holding up the reassembled communicator. "The Colonel reported a similar armoured wall blocking their way. So, we can assume that this isn't limited to just those two spots. Apophis probably has several areas of the palace prepared like this."

"Well, let's cut through it!" Catra moved to the wall they were looking at and lashed out with her claws - only to wince, then frown when, instead of a hole, she had only left shallow cuts, as Adora saw. "That's a thick wall. I guess Apophis expected a lot of explosives."

Adora nodded. "I should be able to cut through it, though." She had yet to find anything that She-Ra's sword couldn't cut.

"Wait!" Sam snapped. "Let's scan it first."

"We're a little bit pressed for time," Catra objected.

"We already missed one trap," Sam countered. "Let's not run into the next."

"Yes." That was sensible. Adora nodded again, and Entrapata and Sam used Entrapta's multitool that Bra'ta had handed over.

“It’s reinforced with a Naquadah-alloy,” Sam said after a moment. “And it includes the ceilings and floor.”

Entrapta nodded. “But in the centre… That layer doesn’t make sense from a structural point of view.”

After a moment spent scanning more in-depth, Sam gasped. “It’s a charge. Like reactive armour.”

“Cut too deeply, and the explosion blasts you?” Catra asked.

“If the explosion is triggered, it will blast most of the area,” Sam replied. “There’s a chance that cutting won’t trigger the explosion, but with the forces involved, and the nature of your sword, I do not think that the risk can be easily dismissed.

Adora winced. That meant…

“We are trapped here,” Catra said. “Better tell Jack before he tries to blast his way through.”

“I don’t think the explosives he has with him can damage the armoured shell,” Sam said. She still informed him, though.

Adora agreed - Jack was crafty and might rig up a more powerful explosion.

Entrapta shook her head, looking up from her tool. “How did we miss this? My tool’s scanner didn’t have the range to detect the walls from further away, but we hacked his security system! There was no sign of this there! How did it trigger?”

“He would have kept this off the main security system - a nasty surprise for any traitor or assassin,” Bra’tac said.

“Oh! So, he’d lose the synergy advantage that combining multiple security systems provides but gains better compartmentalisation.” Entrapta nodded. “That makes sense. But installing this would have taken a long time and a lot of workers, and since he has no

bots that can be memory wiped, keeping it compartmentalised must have been hard."

"Not as long as all workers were killed after finishing their work," Bra'tac told her before Adora could stop him.

She winced at Entrapta's expression.

"But…" Entrapta shook her head. "That's…"

"He is evil," Bra'tac said. "He would not hesitate to sacrifice millions to preserve his life - or win against a rival."

"But… that doesn't make sense! Not even if you don't care about people does it make sense." Entrapta shook her head. "He would have lost so many talented, skilled workers…"

"That's one of the Goa'uld's weaknesses," Catra said. "But we can discuss that once we're out of here."

"I could get us to the Stargate - if you, you know…" Glimmer looked at Adora.

Adora pressed her lips together. She could restore the planet's magic, but that would leave Apophis in possession of a world with magic. And one of his most developed ones, with a lot of people. Some of them probably would have a talent for magic. And Apophis was thousands of years old - he was alive when magic was everywhere. He would recognise the signs and know how to exploit it - those people thought he was their god…

Not to mention she'd have to use all that magic power rushing through her when she unlocked magic on a planet.

"We can hack into this system!" Entrapta suggested. "It has to have a control system."

"And it has to have a way out in case it is triggered with Apophis inside," Catra added. "He wouldn't risk being stuck inside his

palace if a more powerful enemy or an alliance attacked him. Or suffocate if the air runs out."

Adora shuddered at the image this conjured. That would be an awful death - like in a collapsed mine.

"We could probably rig up a way to shelter from the explosion," Sam suggested. "If we build a makeshift bunker far enough…"

"Strong enough so we survive it here?" Catra looked doubtful.

Adora shared her doubts. If they were wrong about the power of the explosion… And all the helpless servants would be at risk as well.

"I think I can predict the bomb's yield so that we can avoid that," Sam said.

Catra scoffed. "You think?"

Adora stepped up before her friends started a row. "Let's try something less dangerous first. Entrapta, Sam - try to hack the new system. Everyone else - look for a secret way out. But don't get split up - we don't know if there are more people in here who're willing to fight for Apophis."

"Alright!"

"And if we don't find a way out?" Glimmer asked as Sam and Entrapta moved ahead to check the metal wall Bra'tac had mentioned, with Bra'tac following them to keep them safe.

"Then you can make yourself useful as transport," Catra said.

Adora frowned at her lover- It was correct, but she would have worded it differently. "Just be careful," she said, picking up Sha're.

"Alright." Catra smiled, but Adora thought she was just humouring her.

“So, if Apophis wanted a way out of here, it would probably be located in Amaunet’s quarters since he’d spend most of his time here there,” Adora said.

“If he trusts her not to betray him,” Catra pointed out. “But even so, it should be close to her bedroom. Let’s start there.” She looked at Glimmer. “Unless you disagree? You’re the expert on palaces.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes. “We’re not Goa’uld.”

“Yeah, you’re not small enough to take over someone’s body.”

Adora sighed as she followed her friends to Amaunet’s quarters - well, once they found them.

*****

Even for a System Lord, Apophis is paranoid, Samantha Carter couldn’t help thinking as she and Entrapta started hacking his second security system. To prepare such a trap in advance, on the chance that some could defeat his primary security system… Was this aimed at SG-1? As a trap? They had managed to sneak into his flagship when he attacked Earth, but that had been as much luck as skill - or more so if Sam was honest.

That wasn’t likely, she deduced while they were scanning for the sensors that triggered the wall. If Apophis had wanted to trap them using Teal’c’s family as bait, he could have picked a less crucial location to place his trap - a remote planet, for example. Even if he had to build a special prison for this, it wouldn’t have nearly cost what he must have spent - in resources and lives - for this. And if he honestly expected them to infiltrate his palace, wouldn’t he have taken his queen elsewhere? Amaunet was one of the few Goa’uld to be able to produce larvae. Without a queen, a System Lord depended on someone else to replace the Prim’ta of his Jaffa, and that would require major concessions.

No, she thought after another scan netted them no results - where were those sensors? - Apophis must fear betrayal from

within his own realm. Especially after the attack on his holdings and fleet by unknown forces. So, this was a way to strike back and trap traitors launching a coup, and the fact that it also trapped infiltrators from Earth and Etheria was an incidental result.

"No sensor here either," Entrapta said. "But someone or something must have triggered the wall."

"Amaunet," Sam realised. "She would have had a panic button."

"Oh?" Entrapta turned to scan the Goa'uld, who was still stunned - Sam reminded herself to stun her again as soon as it was safe to do so. "Yes! There's a transmitter hidden in her jewellery!"

"Good." Sam smiled. "If we can disassemble it, we can narrow down our search for the receiver."

It didn't take them long to take the transmitter apart. It was a very simple design - Sam would call it almost primitive, but for such emergency measures, simpler was often better since it generally meant fewer ways that it might malfunction.

But it also meant any receiver didn't need to be advanced either.

"Oh… it sends a coded transmission on a general frequency," Entrapta summed up their results. "The receiver could be anything - it could even be powered by the energy of the transmission."

"We can duplicate it, then," Sam said.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded, then frowned. "But what if that triggers another reaction?"

That was… possible, Sam had to admit. But how likely was it that Apophis and Amaunet would risk accidentally triggering something because they triggered it twice by accident? It was meant to be used in an emergency. On the other hand, that could be avoided by a simple timer that delayed registering a second signal for a set amount of time. And Apophis was the type of System Lord

who would probably plan to take his enemies with him if he was trapped without a way out. Although, would he hand such a trigger over to Amaunet? She might decide to take him with her, should he turn against her. “Let’s risk it,” Sam said.

“OK! I’ll set the scanner to detect a receiver powering up in range.”

Sam nodded and picked up the transmitter. “Ready.”

“Ready!”

Sam triggered it and tensed. But nothing happened.

“Alright! I found the receiver! And No sign of poison gas or anything like it!” Entrapta cheered.

With the receiver found, they only had to isolate and power it to find the link to the rest of the system. That didn’t take more than five minutes - but Sam was very aware that wherever Apophis was, he would have been alerted the very moment the walls came down. And the more time he had, the worse his reaction would be. And the Colonel was trapped in the dungeons - without Apophis’s queen as leverage or incentive not to simply try to kill everyone inside the wall.

She had to hold herself back from rushing things. If everything else failed, they could activate the world’s magic to get out with Glimmer’s power.

The minute they spent hacking into the system still felt much longer. But they managed it.

“Yes! We’re inside! Now let’s check the data… oh!” Entrapta’s voice fell.

Sam pressed her lips together. The system could only lower the walls - it had no way to pull them back. They had wasted all this time with nothing to show for it.

Except for the fact that this did support the hypothesis that there had to be a secret way out for Apophis and Amaunet. They wouldn't risk being cut off from their troops in the case of a coup and rely on loyalist forces to free them.

"Let's go help the others," she said. Entrapta's scanner had a limited range due to the power restrictions its size brought with it, but they should be able to find secret passages that the others might have missed.

*****

Apophis was one sneaky bastard. Catra clenched her teeth as she forced herself to focus on the task at hand. And since he was a sneaky bastard, he would have a way out - people like him were not keen on dying with his troops. And having an escape route ready was basic tactics. They drilled that into Horde cadets, at least in the command track.

And it would have to be located where he and his queen could get to it quickly. Which meant in or near his or, in this case, since they were in the harem, her quarters. But no matter where Catra looked, she couldn't find it. The usual spots behind potted plants or tapestries were all busts - Catra had clawed enough walls to know. At least these walls weren't as hard as the ones trapping them. Slicing at those hadn't been pleasant.

Maybe Apophis had planned to escape without his host? Slither away as a snake, leave a decoy to die, and make the enemy think they killed you? That would certainly be like him, and he'd only need a tiny tunnel or pipe to get away. On the other hand, would he risk being stuck outside a host in such a crisis? He'd be very vulnerable and wouldn't have any easy way to prove himself to his loyal minions. Except for taking them over, of course.

Wait! She blinked. Pipes! "Oh, that's sneaky!" she hissed and dashed towards the private baths of the queen. As with everything else in her quarters, Apophis hadn't spared any expense when it came to his queen's private bath. The tub was

big enough to serve as a swimming pool. If it were any bigger, Mermista would probably claim it as part of Salineas. But big pools needed big pipes, so a pipe big enough to travel through wouldn't look too suspicious to anyone checking building plans. Like a saboteur.

She stopped at the edge of the pool, peering down at the bottom. Yes, there was an opening set in the bottom. Large enough for a human to pass through. But to use it, you'd have to either dive and let the water push you through - she shuddered at the thought of getting stuck and drowning in the pipe. Or just diving in general - or you'd have to let the water out first.

She didn't see any diving gear stashed nearby, so she looked for the mechanism to release the water. It would normally be used by servants to clean the pool, so it couldn't be obvious - anything servants did in palaces was usually done discreetly, as far as she knew - but it would also be easily accessible…

Ah! Right outside the bath, there was a small alcove with cleaning supplies hidden behind a tapestry. On the wall there, Catra found a control panel. "I think I found it!" she called out to the others.

Adora quickly arrived, followed by Glimmer - and Entrapta, still carrying Amaunet, with Sam. Good. They could analyse the controls - Catra was sure that Apophis didn't want to end up in the sewers - or have a servant accidentally open his escape route when cleaning the bath - so there probably was more to it than pushing a button.

*****

A few minutes later, Catra's suspicion was confirmed.

"Yes, if you push the buttons to open and close the drain simultaneously, it opens the drain and sends another signal out," Entrapta said. "That goes to a sensor in the pipe checking for water."

“So, once the water’s gone, the sensor reroutes the pipe,” Adora said. “Or something like it.”

“Exactly!”

“Well, time to leave, then.” Catra grinned. She cocked her head and put her fingers on both buttons. “Got anything you need to do before we leave? A parting message for Apophis?”

“No,” Adora replied seriously, shaking her head. “The less he knows about us, the better.”

None of the others said anything, so Catra pushed the buttons. Her ears picked up the sound of water rushing through the drain. The pool was already halfway empty when they entered the bath again. A minute later, only puddles remained on the bottom.

“I’ll go first,” Adora declared. “If I make it, all of us will fit.”

And if she didn’t, she could shrink by changing back. Or cut her way out. Catra nodded. She might not like her lover risking herself like that, but it made sense.

Adora took a deep breath and jumped into the hole. Catra heard her body slide through the pipe - tube - as they waited. If this was a trap… She clenched her teeth. The others had hacked the sensor; it didn’t check for anything but the water, so they shouldn’t need some badge or transmitter to reroute the tube.

But a bit of worry remained - until her ears twitched, and she heard Adora yelling: “It’s clear!” from below.

“It’s clear!” she repeated. “Let’s go!”

She jumped into the tube, clenching her teeth when she slid over the still-wet metal, down the pipe. It was like a waterslide from Earth, she told herself. Just completely closed.

And it was over in seconds. The tube suddenly evened out, and a moment later, she shot out of it into a bright room. Catra twisted

and landed on all fours, sliding a yard - and barely managed to jump out of the way before Glimmer rammed into the pad mounted on the wall in front of her.

Glimmer wasn't as quick, but Adora pulled her away before Sam arrived, followed by Entrpa and Amaunet, with Bra'tac bringing up the rear.

Catra looked around. They were in a small room with a sturdy door - and the walls to the side were lined with stuff. Armour, tools, wigs - and weapons!

She moved to check the door. It was unlocked. And behind it…

She grinned. How nice of Apophis to provide them with everything they needed to escape his palace!

*****

"Alright, folks, we've got a bit of a problem, but we're working on it!" Jack O'Neill said with forced cheer.

Bow nodded. "We're trapped in an armoured box that's also rigged to explode, and we can't get to the layer of explosives without using enough force to trigger the explosive. It's a problem, yes."

Jack glanced at him. Bow looked and sounded as if he was earnest, but this was coming a bit close to being sarcastic.

"We've been working on it," Daniel said. "But nothing we have tried or thought of has worked."

Jack frowned. Now, that was gloomy. And they couldn't have that. "We'll get out of here! We haven't tried everything yet. And we won't let our friends show us up by rescuing us!" He clapped Bow on the back. "Our resident tech master will find a way to get through all this armour plate, and then we'll disarm the biggest shaped charge ever built!"

Daniel narrowed his eyes. “The biggest shaped charge that you would have triggered if the others hadn’t told us about the trap.”

Now, that was unfair! Jack was about to defend himself - how could he have suspected such a crazy scheme? - when Bow shook his head and said: “That wouldn’t have happened. We don’t have enough explosives to blow through the wall, which would trigger the blast. But I think we could try to melt a very small hole down to the explosive layer in the floor using one of my arrows. It’ll be a bit tricky since the arrow carries only a little bit of acid, enough to melt through a Horde tank’s armour, but I should be able to manage that with the tools we have here.”

That wasn’t how acid worked, in Jack’s experience. But Bow’s trick arrows were magitech, and that was more ‘anything goes’.

“And then?” Daniel asked.

“Then we see how we can disarm the explosives,” Jack said.

“And then? We’re on the lowest level of the palace.”

“The lowest level in use - but they have to have pipes and maintenance tunnels down there,” Jack pointed out. Unless the snakes used some alien tech to get around that. But they’d cross that bridge once they reached it.

Daniel still looked doubtful, but he nodded. Good.

And if this plan didn’t work, they’d think of something else. Or the others would save them, probably by Glimmer teleporting them out. Which wasn’t ideal - it would mean restoring magic to Apophis’s planet and exposing their powers - but still better than suffocating in the sealed dungeons. Or getting captured by Apophis and snaked. After being tortured for a long, long while.

Jack would rather trigger the explosives himself than suffer that, and he was sure everyone else would agree. Not that it would happen, anyway. But if it did, having a way to touch off that massive charge would come in handy.

At least everyone was staying calm. Bow was busy working, Daniel was holding it together - it helped that the other group had secured Sha're - and Teal'c was talking to his family in the other corner. Jack couldn't hear what they were saying, but Ryla'c looked happy, and Drey'auc hadn't tried to tear off her husband's head, so it looked like it was going pretty well. At least compared to their general situation.

But if they couldn't get out, it wouldn't matter. And it was Jack's job to ensure they could get out. Alive and unharmed. Or at least alive - Adora could heal any wound, anyway.

"OK!" Bow held up one of his few trick arrows. One with a tip that looked like a green vial. "I've altered the tip so it'll release the acid in a very small trickle!"

"Good work!" Jack was more than a little queasy about handling a vial designed to break upon impact that contained enough acid to melt a tank's armour, but like Hell, he'd show it - a leader had to remain confident at all times. "Let's see how it works!"

"Well, we'll have to go through the normal floor first. We can't waste the acid on that," Bow said, smiling a bit sheepishly.

"No problem," Jack told him, hefting a pilfered staff weapon. The hidden armour would withstand a staff blast, so it should be safe to shoot a hole into the floor until you hit the armour layer.

And blasting stuff was an *excellent* way to release tension and work off frustration. Jack knew that from experience.

"Everyone, stay back! It's going to get loud!" he announced, aiming the staff at the ground in the corner farthest from everyone else.

Daniel scrambled to join Teal'c in the other corner, and Jack waited until Bow and his acid bomb were clear as well before he started shooting.

A bit later, his ears were ringing, but he was looking at the shiny and now slightly scorched reinforced armour in the hole in the floor. “Alright, you’re up,” he told Bow.

“OK! “ Bow approached the hole, then took a step back. “I think we better let it cool down a bit,” he said.

“Yeah, I think so too:” Jack could feel the heat from a few yards away. And when he dropped some water from the guard’s stash on the armour, it sizzled.

But it didn’t take too long for the metal to cool down enough so Bow could set up his contraption, and a bit later, the thing started dropping acid on the armour.

One drop at a time.

“I might have to adjust the drop rate,” Bow said, unasked, after the first drop had hit the armour plate. “But it’s working.”

“And when we reach the explosives? What then?” Daniel asked.

“Then we figure out a way to disarm them,” Jack said. Something. Anything.

Daniel gave him a look that showed he didn’t really think much of their chances.

Jack kept smiling. He didn’t think this had much of a chance to work, either, but a small chance was better than no chance at all. And it kept them too busy and distracted to panic.

*****

“A Tel’tak. Modified and likely equipped with a stealth device for ease of escaping an attack on the planet itself,” Bra’tac said, looking at the small ship they had discovered behind the door.

“Oh!” Entrapta beamed at it. “We have to analyse it - this could be the key to miniaturising our own stealth generators!”

Adora looked around in the small hangar. They had to be a bit below the palace's basement if she had correctly calculated their descent through the tube. But not too deeply underground.

"I do not think we have the time for that," Sam told Entrapta.

"But we'll have all the time we need once we're back on Earth!"

"It won't fit through the gate," Catra told her. "And we'll have to scan it thoroughly for a bomb and other traps," she added. "Apophis must be really paranoid about a coup, so I bet he has some nasty surprise hidden here as well."

Adora nodded. A ruler who'd install a failsafe lined with explosives would also prepare to blow up an obvious escape craft.

"I think our covert attacks and the failure of his false flag attack on PZ-921 must have convinced him that he has traitors in his court," Glimmer said, shifting her grip on the staff weapon she had taken from Apophis's stash.

Catra snorted.

"He would already be aware of that," Bra'tac commented. "The false gods are always ready to betray each other. But he would suspect one or more of them being about to move on him in this case, I would say."

"Great." Catra shook her head. "That's good for fighting him in the field, but it makes covert ops more difficult."

"And the purges will endanger the Tok'ra spies," Glimmer added.

Bra'tac looked as if he wanted to comment, but before he said anything, Sam spoke up: "We've found a bomb."

"Yes," Entrapta added. "It's placed at the main drive, so detecting it was a bit of a challenge."

"Can you disarm it quickly?" Adora asked.

“Let us check!”

“Are you planning to use the ship to flee the planet?” Bra’tac asked as Entrapta headed inside the ship, followed by Sam.

“As a last resort,” Adora replied. “But we can use it to fly out of here.”

“And then return to the palace to grab the others!” Catra grinned. “Apophis wouldn’t suspect that.”

“He is aware of the loyalty the Tau’ri show towards each other,” Bra’tac said. “He would not expect SG-1 to abandon their own.”

“Would he expect an offer to exchange his queen for them?” Glimmer asked.

Bra’ac tilted his head, obviously pondering this for a moment. “Potentially, yes. But I cannot say what his state of mind will be after a direct attack on his palace. This will cost him a lot of face, and being forced to negotiate for his queen would make it even worse. It will make him appear weak to all his rivals, both outside and inside his court.”

“We’re not planning to exchange Amaunet for the others,” Adora told him. They had no way to safely extract her from Sha’re, anyway. And they wouldn’t abandon Sha’re.

“Or expect him to deal honestly with us.” Catra scoffed. “But if he thinks we left the planet, that will help us save the others.”

“And we can send such an offer to throw him off our real plan,” Glimmer said. “If we have to,” she added. “Not dealing honestly with him would make it harder to negotiate with others.”

Bra’tac frowned at that. “Negotiating with the false gods is a recipe for disaster. They have no honour and will betray their own without the slightest hesitation if they think it will improve their position even a little.”

That sounded a bit biased in Adora's opinion. More than a bit. Then again, Bra'ta had been Apophis's Prime for decades - he would know him best. "It's not just the Goa'uld," she said. "But how can we expect others, like the Jaffa, to trust us if we act like that?" Honesty was the best policy.

"They will be aware that dealing honestly with the false gods is a foolish proposition and not judge us for this," Bra'ta retorted. But Adora thought he sounded a little defensive.

"Alright! We disarmed the bomb. And we also spoofed the tracking devices hidden in the ship!" Entrapta waved at them from the ramp leading into the Tel'tak. "It should be safe now."

"And does it have a stealth device?" Adora asked.

"Yes! Although it doesn't seem as effective as our own." Entrapta pouted.

"You said it was modified. Does it have missile launchers?" Catra asked. "We could launch the tracking devices and send Apophis on a chase into space."

"No," Sam said. "The only weapons it has are two staff weapons."

That was… not very impressive.

"Normal Tel'taks are unarmed," Bra'tac added.

"Ah." Catra shrugged. "Well, let's go! We have people to save."

"Yes." Adora nodded firmly. They wouldn't leave anyone behind.

"Indeed."

Now they just had to figure out how they would save the others.

*****

The others were trapped in the palace dungeons, locked in by armoured walls with an explosive layer - under specific

circumstances, it might act as reactive armour. Might that be a way to get through it? Unlikely. Based on their scans of the harem walls, the reinforced armour would withstand the blast from the explosive layer in either direction.

Samantha Carter was briefly distracted from her attempts to find a way to save their friends when Bra'tac started the engine, and the Tel'tak rose to float in the hangar.

A moment later, the hangar doors slid back in the walls, revealing a tunnel leading up to the surface. A concealed exit would be waiting for them at the end, probably rigged to be blown open once the ship drew closer. But what if an inhabited building might conceal the exit? Apophis would have no scruples to kill dozens, hundreds of people to escape!

"We need to stop and scan the exit before we open it," she said. "We don't want to blast our way free through a residual building."

"We cannot take the risk," Bra'tac retorted at once as he guided the craft up the tunnel. "Apophis will soon be aware of our escape - if he wasn't informed already by automated systems. He will be moving to block the exit."

"We can't risk killing innocent people!" Adora blurted out.

"We can check with our scanner," Entrapta offered. "We'll be in range soon… just stop when I say so!"

Bra'tac looked like he wanted to argue but nodded after a glance at Adora.

A few seconds later, they stopped at Entrapta's command.

"Alright, let's see… Oh."

The exit was indeed concealed beneath a building, Sam saw on the scanner. But it was a barracks building, not slave housing - the people inside were armed, carrying staff weapons that showed up on the scanner.

“He would blow up his own guards?” Glimmer shook her head.

“In the eyes of Apophis, the fact that he was forced to flee his palace would mean they have failed him, for their duty is to protect him from any kind of attack. Whether they failed or betrayed him, the false god would see death as a fitting punishment,” Bra’tac said.

“We could scare them away with an alert after hacking the security system, I think,” Entrapta suggested. “Or… Oh! They are moving.”

The markers showing the positions of the Jaffa inside the barracks were indeed moving - towards the exit. “Apophis must have alerted them!” Sam said.

“He will attempt to lock us in here,” Bra’tac snapped.

“Push on. We need to leave before they manage to set up a blockade!” Catra said.

“Do it,” Adoara agreed.

Bra’tac was already moving the Tel’tak further ahead.

They might be too late, Sam knew. If Apophis had a remote command to block the exit… But would he risk that a rival or traitor could use that to trap him if he needed to flee? Unlikely.

She was still relieved when the tunnel suddenly shook, and the scanner’s readings showed the building being blown clear a moment before the doors ahead of them opened, and the Tel’tak flew straight into a cloud of smoke.

Bra’tac activated the stealth device and then quickly accelerated. A moment later, they shot out of the smoke cloud.

“Death Gliders!” Catra yelled.

“We’re hidden,” Bra’tac replied.

But the enemy craft were shooting in their direction. Had Sam and Entrapta missed a tracker?

No, the shots went wide - and hit the cloud. They had been dragging some smoke with them as they flew out of the cloud, Sam realised, giving away their initial position.

But Bra'tac was manoeuvring now, banking to turn back towards the palace, and the Death Gliders were still shooting at the slowly rising smoke cloud. Sam winced when she saw shots hitting the streets and buildings below - and the people on the ground.

But there was nothing they could do about that, and she had to focus on how to save their friends. The walls had come down, locking them in. And there was no quick way to raise the walls from either side - Apophis had intended them to lock traitors in or out. Would there be an escape tunnel like the one they had used? In the dungeons? Very unlikely, Sam decided. Apophis wouldn't risk that. He could have prisoners brought to him if he wanted to personally interrogate or just torture them. That also ruled out a ring transporter set up to reach the dungeons.

They stopped in front of the palace - to the side, actually, in case an enemy craft approached the entrance or the landing pads above it.

"Now, how do we get back inside?" Entrapta asked. "And how do we get our friends out? Maybe we can construct a drill that won't trigger the explosives? Though that would take a long time…"

Sam shook her head. Trying to find a way inside through the armoured walls was the wrong way to tackle this. She knew the layout of the walls now. There was no way to quickly raise the walls - they had no machinery installed to do that - but they could be raised from the outside. It would take an attacker long enough to let Apophis escape since they had to bring in cranes or hydraulic lifts - or gravitational manipulators - and install them to lift the walls.

They couldn’t do any of that. But sooner or later, Apophis would be ordering his guards to do that to get to the trapped team inside the dungeons.

And that would grant them an opportunity to intervene. They didn’t have heavy machinery to do the lifting. But Apophis’s troops would have access to the machines needed...

Sam nodded. “I have an idea.”

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Outside the Palace of Apophis, Saqqara, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“I don’t like this plan,” Catra muttered as their freshly stolen hoversled - or whatever the Goa’uld called their floating transports - stopped in front of the palace’s gates. And it wasn’t because she was wearing equally stolen worker robes again, which restricted her tail.

“We know. You told us so. Several times already,” Glimmer whispered. “Now shut up!”

“It bears repeating.” Sneaking into the palace disguised as slaves for the second time? Third time if you counted the harem infiltration separately? Sure, Apophis wouldn’t expect that - because it was a damn dumb plan! Trying the same thing three times was a recipe for disaster. Not even the Princess Alliance at its worst had been that gullible!

Fortunately, fighting their way inside was a valid backup plan. They already knew the layout, they still had the primary security system hacked - Sam had checked - and Apophis’s troops would be limited to infantry inside the palace and wouldn’t be able to match or stop She-Ra. Well, unless the Jaffa blew up their own walls, but they could work around that. Probably.

She was eyeing the gate guards - she could take the two standing to the side while Adora barrelled into the main force in the centre,

and the others could kill the warriors who had brought them here - when the guard commander waved them on, yelling at them for being late. No checking under their robes and cloaks, no questioning their orders - though they had valid orders, taken when they took the hoversled carrying the gravity lifters or whatever Entrapta had dubbed them. The only ones getting checked were the Jaffa with them, and those were actual guards who - and wouldn't enter the palace anyway.

It seemed like their foolhardy plan was going to work. Catra steadily focused on the potential threats as they entered the palace. And not on her undoubtedly smirking lover. They weren't out of danger yet, anyway. The only one relatively safe was Bra'tac back in the Tel'tak, with the stunned and secured Amaunet and the stunned workers originally assigned to the hoversleds and gravity lifters.

"Move faster! The great Apophis is impatient!" one of the palace guards now escorting them snapped as they turned a corner.

Catra clenched her teeth and sped the hoversled up a bit - and resisted the temptation to accelerate even more and 'accidentally' bump the guard into the wall with it. Just a bit further…

It seemed that every hallway crossing was now guarded by Jaffa. Yet none of them stopped them to check the slaves' identities, only their escorts'. As Bra'tac had said, the arrogance of the Goa'ud and their warriors would be their downfall.

Until they wised up, at least. You couldn't count on the enemy not adapting.

They reached a lift that looked like the one they had taken down to the vault, entered past more guards, and then waited inside while they descended.

Her ears, flattered by her cowl, picked up Sam whispering into their communicator, informing O'Neill and the others that they

were close. He sounded a little tense under all his flippant comments, in her opinion, as he acknowledged that.

Then the lift stopped - they had arrived. More nervous guards hurried them on, towards an apparently freshly created hole in the floor. Catra stopped the hoversled next to it and used the opportunity to peer into it. Yes, that was the armoured wall down below. And the hole had been so recently created, its walls were still hot - as was the barrel of the staff canon the Jaffa had used to make it.

It didn't take long to place the gravity lifter over the hole, even though half a dozen Jaffa screaming at them to hurry up wasn't helping at all. But despite that, Catra could hear the Jaffa down below, massing to storm the dungeons as soon as the wall in front of them was lifted.

It looked as if everything was ready.

"We're ready," Glimmer told the Jaffa leader.

"Finally! You will be punished for your failure to arrive more promptly!"

"No, I don't think she will," Adora told him.

"What?" He looked up from his communicator just in time to catch her fist to the face and fell down the hole.

Catra was already in the air, tearing her robes off. She threw them at the closest guard, blinding him long enough for her to rake all four claws of hers over his partner as she came down. She hit the ground on all fours, then whirled, sweeping the first guard off his feet with her legs just as he dropped the robes. A swipe with her right hand tore through his armour and his throat before he could aim or swing at her.

Next to her, Adora threw another guard down the hole. He screamed until he hit the top of the wall below. "That was the last," she said. "Lift the wall!"

Entrapta’s hair flew over the controls, and the lifter started to hum. A moment later, Catra heard metal sliding against metal, and the wall below began to move upward.

And Adora jumped down the hole.

*****

The Rescue Operation Part 4

Palace of Apophis, Saqqara, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"They're about to raise the wall!"

As soon as he heard Bow's announcement, Jack O'Neill snapped: "Everyone, get ready!" and ducked behind the remains of the console, staff weapon aimed at the door. If only he had his gun! He'd prefer a zat, but the staff weapon was more effective against multiple enemies about to rush you.

He quickly glanced at the rest of the group. Teal'c was at the corner, staff aimed, not showing any tension. Bow was next to him, arrow notched but not yet drawn. And Daniel was in the corridor leading to the cells, zat ready to shoot at anyone running towards him, flanked by Ryla'c and Drey'auc. Having those two with weapons at his back made Jack a little nervous. Not because they might betray them. But they were civilians with weapons, thrust into a battle. Jaffa civilians, but still. At least Teal'c saw nothing wrong with it, and Jack trusted his friend.

The wall started to rise, and Jack tensed. If they shot a grenade through the gap… he got ready to blast it back.

But instead of a grenade, he heard screams and shots. And blasts from staff weapons.

"Hold fire!" Bow yelled, holding his communicator. "Adora jumped down!"

Ah. That explained it. Jack grinned as the wall quickly rose, revealing She-Ra in full armour fighting a few dozen Serpent Guards. They were shooting staff weapons and zats at her, to no effect. And in the back, he saw a group setting up a staff cannon.

A couple of blasts from him and Teal'c put an end to that, wrecking both the cannon and the crew.

To the left, Bow had hit three guards with a net arrow, entangling all of them. They were still struggling and trying to bring their weapons to bear, though, so Jack took them out with a blast from his staff weapon.

The wall had risen all the way to the top at that point. Adora charged forward, her sword turning into a shield to smash two Jaffa into three others, then changed back to slice through a fourth.

But more came running out of a side corridor. Teal'c caught the first with a shot to the chest that threw the guard back, and Jack shot the next one as he stumbled over the body, but then he had to duck when the rest opened up with a volley of blasts that finished wrecking the console more and blew up more of the guard room.

Things were getting heated. Jack clenched his teeth, took a deep breath and rushed out of his rapidly disintegrating cover to the entrance of the prison sector, drawing and wildly firing his zat one-handed.

A staff blast missed him but blew up the floor behind him, and he felt fragments hit his armour - and his bare legs.

The pain followed a moment later when he slid into the corner next to the door, out of the Jaffa's field of fire. Gritting his teeth, he quickly checked his leg. Nothing serious. He could still run.

"Watch out!"

"Hold fire! The others are coming!" Bow, now across from him in the other corner next to the door, yelled.

Jack leaned around the corner and caught a figure landing on a Jaffa trying to get into Adora's rear. Catra. She drove the guard into the floor, then ripped his neck open with a swipe of her claws.

Jack grimaced as she leaned out a bit more, checked above for anyone else dropping by, and shot a Jaffa who was getting up

after Adora had smashed into him.

More shots from above followed. A couple of not-very-well-aimed staff blasts that at least suppressed another Jaffa rush and a zat shot that took out another wounded Jaffa. That would be Glimmer and Carter, respectively.

Jack forced himself to ignore the pain in his legs and get up, then push on. They had to get out of here. "Just how many guards does Apophis have?" he muttered as he moved through the door, then crouched down on the other side.

"This is his capital," Teal'c replied, mirroring his move on the other side - which forced Bow, who had been about to do the same, to fall back, Jack noted.

"Set up our present!" he yelled at him. Bow didn't have many arrows, and with everyone else joining the battle, he wouldn't be very effective either.

"Alright!"

"Make way! Whee!"

He glanced up again and almost gasped. Entrapta was climbing down the hole, her hair tendrils reaching from wall to wall - and half-carrying Glimmer and Carter. It looked like out of a movie.

Shaking his head, he advanced some more, shooting at a straggler. Teal'c did the same, securing the other flank.

By the time Entrapta reached the ground, the Jaffa had been driven back into the hallways they had used to gather for the assault. They would rally again, though.

"Everyone, come on - time to leave!" Jack yelled. The longer they stayed, the more troops Apophis could bring in.

"Where is Sha're?" Daniel asked as he and Teal'c's family joined them.

“She’s with Bra’tac,” Carter told him before addressing Jack. “Sir, it looks like a regiment of guards is covering the upper levels.”

That complicated things.

*****

A regiment? Adora looked around - there were no enemies left near her. None who were alive or awake, at least. But that was a large number of guards to go through. “They’re blocking all the exits?”

“Yes,” Sam replied.

“Then we’ll have to make our own exits,” she said. “As long as we avoid more such walls, we should be able to cut through any wall - or ceiling.”

“And we can use the gravity sled,” Entrapta added.

Catra cocked her head to the side. “We could - if the guards hadn’t blown it up right now.”

That meant they would soon be coming through the shaft they had left leading up - or dropping bombs down. “Let’s move!” Adora snapped and moved forward.

As the others followed her, Jack turned and shot the controls of the door behind them as soon as it closed. “That should slow any pursuit. If only I had some spare charges…”

“We could rig one from the staff weapons,” Catra suggested.

“That will take too long. We need to move,” Adora cut in. “Come on.” She turned to Entrapta and the others. “Plot a route to the surface. Don’t bother with lifts and stairs.”

“But look out for traps,” Catra added - unnecessarily, in Adora’s opinion. Their friends knew what to do.

Sam ignored the comment, but Entrapta nodded. “Alright! If we stick to the route we took going in, there shouldn’t be any traps. Though… Hmm…”

“I think we should take an angled route,” Sam said, pointing at the display on Entrapta’s tool. “Here!”

“Oh, yes!” Entrapta’s hair flared out, then formed a hand, finger pointing at the ceiling. “Cut here!”

Adora nodded, hefted her sword and jumped. Two curved slashes later, she dropped to the floor and caught a piece of the ceiling, grunting at the effort - and with surprise when Catra jumped on top of the ceiling piece, then up through the hole. “Catra!”

“Clear!” her lover yelled back. “Hurry and come up!”

“Well, we don’t have a gravity sled,” Glimmer said, eyeing the hole.

“I should be able to…”

Adora lowered the piece she was holding. “Step on it.”

“Right!”

Adora had to lift it up twice. Not because of the weight - she could throw a tank; the steel piece, even with all their friends on it, was no problem. But the piece she had cut was too small to fit everyone, even with Entrapta using her hair to climb up.

But they all arrived safely on the floor above them and quickly moved to the next spot Entrapta and Sam had picked.

This time, a group of guards must have heard the floor dropping off, but Catra made short work of them before Adora could set down the platform and jump up.

The next floor, though, had Jaffa shooting at them as soon as Adora dropped down, and…

“Grenade!” Catra yelled.

Adora gasped, then flung the floor piece up as everyone dived into cover. A moment later, something exploded above her, and the slab of metal she had hurled came back down in pieces.

“That didn’t take out everyone!” Catra snapped, already moving towards the hole.

Adora beat her to it, though, pushing the fragments on her away and jumping straight up. A zat blast hit her on the way up, but she ignored it. Two staff weapons fired at her when she landed on the floor above. She caught both on her shield and charged.

A Jaffa on the ground, hurt by their own grenade, tried to raise, but without stopping, she kicked him in the head, sending him flying against the wall. Then she crashed into the line of Jaffa facing her and bowled them over.

A moment later, her shield changed into a sword, and she slashed at the groaning guards before they could recover.

She whirled. Catra was already laying into the surviving guards on the other side, followed by Teal’c arriving in the hole, pushed up by Entrapta’s hair. A couple of staff blasts later, the guards were down, and Entrapta brought the rest of the group up.

“The Jaffa are spreading out on the floor above us,” Sam reported. “They must have realised we change the location where we go up.” With a frown, she added: “And they are taking out the cameras - they must have realised we hacked them.”

That limited them to the short range of Entrapta’s scanner in her multitool. Adora briefly bit her lower lip. There was no helping it - they had to continue. “Let’s go!”

They caught the Jaffa by surprise on the next floor, but the guards quickly rallied - and tried to keep their distance, shooting at them from prepared positions instead of rushing in.

“They’re trying to slow us down,” Jack said, gritting his teeth as he poked a burn on his thigh.

It didn’t look too bad, but it must be painful anyway.

“To gain time to bring in more reinforcements?” Catra frowned.

“Something like that,” Jack agreed.

“Then we need to hurry,” Glimmer said.

“And we need to skip the gates,” Catra added. “They’ll expect that.”

“They’ve seen us cut through the floor multiple times,” Bow retorted. “They’ll have to surround the entire palace.”

“We can have Bra’tac fetch us,” Glimmer pointed out. “If we reach a landing pad further up.”

“They’ll cover those gates as well,” Jack said. “But it’s harder to block all of them, and if we’re quick enough, we should be able to get away.”

“Uh…” Entrapta spoke up. “Bra’tac just sent us a message: A Ha’tak is descending on the palace.”

*****

A Ha’tak? If it was bringing reinforcements, it could land directly on the palace to deliver them. Or to pick up Apophis if the System Lord was present - taking command of a Ha’tak would give him an excuse to leave his palace in the middle of a crisis.

Either way, the ship could cover every entrance with its guns.

Samantha Carter looked at the Colonel. “Sir, if they target the gates or any opening we make…”

“...we won’t have the time to embark on Bra’tac’s ship, yes.” He nodded with a grim expression.

“We need a distraction,” Catra said. “Something to draw their attention and fire away from the real exit.”

“And we need to keep going up,” Adora added. “We can’t waste time. Look for an alternative way out while we move.” She raised her sword, bent her knees and then jumped, striking at the ceiling.

Sam moved back with Entrapta and Bow while the others - mostly Adora, Catra, Teal’c and the Colonel - fought their way up and through the Serpent Guards waiting there.

It was a holding action indeed. By the time she joined the others on the next floor, the Jaffa had fallen back and were attempting spoiling attacks in small numbers. Wasteful but not entirely ineffective, Sam thought.

“Could we fool them into thinking that this is a coup attempt? Make them fight each other?” Glimmer suggested.

“If we had control of their communications,” Sam replied. Which they didn’t have. And the security system was rapidly losing coverage of the rest of the palace, with all the cameras near the Jaffa being destroyed.

“I have an idea. Is the Ha’tak landing?” the Colonel asked.

Sam relayed the question to Bra’tac. It was dangerous - the Tel’tak was in stealth mode, but any communication could theoretically be detected - but justified. And the comm channels had to be full of orders and reports right now.

“It seems to be set on landing on the palace,” Bratac told them.

“Alright. We’ve prepared a surprise for Apophis,” the Colonel said. “I didn’t want to use it while we were still inside the palace, but we don’t have much of a choice. But we need to get to the surface floor before the ship touches down.”

A surprise? What could… Sam's eyes widened. The Colonel couldn't have! Then she saw Bow wincing. No, of course, they could have. "We need to hurry!" she said. And they had to signal Bra'tac so he could be ready to pick them up. They wouldn't have much time to pull this off!

"Then let's go!" Adora announced.

They had two more floors to clear. And they had to reach the outer wall. All before the ship touched down on the top of the palace.

Sam indicated the shortest route to the outer walls, and they sprinted down the hallway, past dead and wounded Serpent Guards. This time, Adora didn't cut a hole into the ceiling - she jumped and smashed a hole into it, using her sword like a ramming tool. And Catra didn't wait for Adora to jump in first and draw fire - she bounced off the wall and disappeared in the cloud of smoke before Adora could jump again.

Sam heard shots from above, followed by screams, and clenched her teeth. As much as she wanted to help fight the Jaffa, she couldn't do much until she was up on the next floor. Not with her weapon, at least.

But she could do other things. The security system was in shambles, but she could still fill it with fake signals. It might not fool the Serpent Guard, who must have received orders not to listen, but the servants and slaves? A few fire alarms might be enough to disrupt whatever Apophis was doing. In a small way, at least.

But then she remembered the likely reaction of the guards to a bunch of panicking slaves trying to run past them - or at them. No, she couldn't do that. Not for such a paltry chance of improving their situation.

Instead, she focused on what intel she could gather with her rapidly shrinking means: The positions of some enemy troops -

and the movements of others. By the time Entrapta's hair put her down on the next floor, she had a new route plotted out.

That left another floor before the surface level. A Ha'tak on a landing approach was slow, but not that slow. "We are running out of time! We have to break through and then immediately go up again - without clearing the area of enemy troops!" she told the others.

"I'll keep them busy on this side," Catra said, pointing towards the inner part of the palace. "You suppress the rest."

"That's…" Adora started to protest.

"We don't have time!" the Colonel snapped. "Do it!"

Adora glared at him but jumped up, once more breaking a hole into the stone ceiling. She managed to get a grip on the broken edge somehow and swung herself up with a roar, followed by Catra. Then Entrapta started to move Teal'c and the Colonel up. Then Glimmer and Bow.

Then it was Sam's turn.

She was dropped on the floor, zat out, and started firing at the Jaffa moving at the end of the corridor. Smoke hindered her aim, but the goal was suppressing them, not taking them out.

A staff blast passed above her head. Teal'c turned and shot down the hallway as well.

"Brace yourself!" Adora yelled.

Then the ceiling exploded, and Sam ducked, holding her arms above her head as metal and stone pieces rained down on them. One hit her shoulder, and she yelled at the pain. Bruised. Not dislocated or broken, she thought, but it was hard to tell. Before she could resume shooting at the enemies, hair tendrils grabbed her and lifted her up to the hole. She reached out to haul herself

up with one arm, but then something exploded below her, and she was falling, the hair releasing her.

Staff weapon blast, she realised a moment before she hit the ground - on her already hurt shoulder. And she couldn't help screaming as the pain grew much, much worse. Broken, probably. She rolled on her back, holding her shoulder, as torn strands of Entrapta's hair floated down on her. Entrapta!

"My hair!"

So, she was alive! Sam smiled despite her wound.

Some appeared at her side. Sam almost shot them - or tried to, using her off hand - before she recognised Catra.

"Get up!"

Before Sam could do so - or say anything about her shoulder - Catra grabbed her and jumped.

And Sam hissed through clenched teeth as her shoulder flared with more pain each time it was jostled.

But she was now on the surface level. And they had to keep moving. Groaning, she got up. Catra had already jumped down again. The Ha'tak would be landing any moment.

She looked around. The Colonel and Teal'c were firing their staff weapons as fast as they cycled, suppressing a group of guards trying to rush them. Catra reappeared, carrying Ryla'c. Entrapta appeared in the hole, hair tendrils moving to pull her up - though not as much as before. And Glimmer and Bow were climbing up the hair tendrils instead of being lifted.

Ryla'c started shooting a staff weapon down the hole. Covering fire for Daniel and Dry'auc, Sam realised.

She crawled to the edge of the hole and added her own fire. Damn, her shoulder hurt!

“The ship’s about to touch down!” Entrapta yelled.

“Tell me when it’s landed!” the Colonel yelled back.

Catra appeared, carrying Daniel. Dry’auc was climbing herself.

Sam fired at the Jaffa charging at them from below. One Jaffa got hit and went down. Another dropped to the side when Ryla’c shot a staff weapon at them. Then Dry’auc reached the surface floor and pulled herself up next to Sam - and exposed her bleeding back to her.

But before Sam could say anything, Entrpata yelled. “The ship has landed!”

“Hit it, Bow!” the colonel yelled.

A moment later, Sam heard a loud explosion - and then the whole building trembled.

*****

The crazy bastard had rigged the charges in the dungeon to explode! Catra grinned as she felt the floor shift slightly under her feet. Then she heard the sound of metal straining and stone cracking and cursed. “We need to leave! Right now!”

Adora was already charging towards the outer wall closest to them. “Call Bra’tac!” she yelled over her shoulder.

“Sam’s hurt!” Entrapta.

“It’s just my shoulder!”

“Everyone’s banged up!” Catra snapped. She had caught some shrapnel herself. Nothing too bad, though. “Call Bra’tac - we need him to pick us up before the ship recovers.”

Adora slashed the wall, once, twice, then kicked it - sending a section flying outwards. Catra could see the sky outside - and

Jaffa on the ground getting up. Damn! That was too much firepower for Adora to cover.

And the sounds from the palace were getting louder, even though the floor wasn't shifting any more… The Ha'tak on top must be mangling the structure!

But there was a staff cannon whose crew had been taken out, next to the opening. Catra dashed forward on all fours, trying to ignore the staff blasts whipping past above her head as everyone started firing, and Adora tried to shield them.

"He's coming! Homing in on our signal!" Entrapta announced.

"Tell him to hurry!" O'Neill snapped.

"I can walk, sir!"

"You stay put!"

The corpse of the Jaffa gunner lay slumped over the controls. Catra kicked it away and started turning the cannon around. Her foot claws dug into the stone floor, but the weapon swivelled until the barrel pointed at the opening. And at Adora's back. "Move right!" Catra yelled.

As soon as Aodra did so, Catra started firing. Her first volley went wide, but she quickly adjusted, and her next blasts wiped out a squad of charging Serpent Guards. She swung the cannon to the side and started raking the grounds with suppressive fire, scattering more ranks of the guards outside.

"Incoming inside!" O'Neill yelled.

More explosions inside followed. Staff blasts. Catra gritted her teeth and kept firing. O'Neill arrived, half-carrying Sam, followed by Daniel and the ragged-looking Entrapta - part of her hair was still smoking. "Bra'tac's almost here!" she announced.

The sound of screeching metal drowned out whatever Daniel said to that. A moment later, a piece of metal and stone the size of a skiff crashed into the ground outside, shattering and throwing up a cloud of dust.

Then a shadow fell over the area outside, and Adora screamed: "Get out! Right now!"

Catra released the cannon's controls - it was overheating anyway - and dashed outside. Looking up, she froze for a moment.

The Ha'tak was looming over them, listing to the side and dragging part of the palace's top with it as its engines were straining to get the ship clear.

Entrapta almost cooed. "Oh! It must have gotten stuck on the pyramid connector when the explosion rocked the structure! The distance would have leveraged the slight shift on the underground level, resulting in…"

"Escape now, physics lesson later!" O'Neill snapped. "Where is Bra'tac?"

Behind him, Dry'auc and Ryla'c appeared in the opening, Teal'c bringing up the rear with Bow and Glimmer.

But the Jaffa outside were rallying, and the fire was picking up. Worse, the guards inside were barely being held back by the others laying down suppressive fire. They were boxed in!

"He's almost here!"

More stone and metal bits slid down the palace's side, one hitting a landing pad and ripping it off. The Ha'tak was slowly righting itself, twisting the landing structure it was stuck on.

Catra's ears twitched - that was an engine noise. A familiar one! It was coming closer! She looked but saw nothing - there! A slight distortion!

A moment later, a door swung open, seemingly from nowhere, revealing the interior of the Tel'tak they had stolen.

"Everyone inside!" O'Neill yelled. "Go! Go! Go!"

But even as he started to run, dragging Sam with him, the Tel'tak's stealth field started to ripple - the Serpent Guards outside shooting at them were hitting the ship instead! Catra clenched her teeth. The shields were deflecting the shots, but that disrupted the stealth field.

And the Jaffa must have realised what that meant since the fire intensified. O'Neill had reached the ship, followed by Daniel. Adora moved to cover the ship from the front, but she couldn't shield it entirely.

Catra picked up a staff weapon and started laying down suppressive fire on their flank while Dry'auc and Ryla'c sprinted to the ramp. "Hurry up!" she yelled to the rest. "They'll call in air support any moment!"

They had already done so, she realised a moment later, when two Death Gliders swooped down, their canons stitching a line of explosions into the ground - and then into the Tel'tak.

The shields flickered but held. Apophis wouldn't have trusted his life to a weak escape vessel, Catra thought. Good for him - and for us!

She started to move towards the ship herself, still firing wildly to break up the Jaffa formations trying to charge them. They just needed a little more time for everyone to…

The sound of stone and metal breaking, tearing, made her look up. The Ha'tak had torn off the top of the palace's pyramid top! And while the ship was stabilising, the structure it had wrecked was falling down in several large and countless smaller pieces - right on them!

“Take cover!” Catra dropped the staff weapon and dashed forward, slamming into Bow and Glimmer as they left the palace and pushing them back inside moments before a slab of stone smashed into the wall above them, shattering the stone and everything below.

She rolled on her side, jumping up - next to Teal’c still covering their rear - and whirled around.

Just in time to see the tip of the pyramid hit the Tel’tak’s shields and shatter them, then crush the ship. She gasped. Adora!

Then the pain hit her, and she noticed the blood running down her side.

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Outside the Palace of Apophis, Saqqara, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

One moment, Jack O’Neill was reaching out to grab Ryla’c to drag the kid to a seat inside the Tel’tak and strap him in. The next, Bra’tac yelled something, and Jack found himself thrown against the wall. And the ceiling. Or the floor - it was hard to tell with all the smoke and…

He blinked and shook his head, glancing around. He was on the floor - and the floor was the wall. Or trying to be. All angled wrong. And broken. Like the rest of it.

The ship was wrecked, he realised, gasping - only to cough when he inhaled smoke. Something was burning. And that meant the whole ship would burn in no time.

“We need to get out!” he yelled, then coughed again. They never got the smoke quite right in crash and rescue drills, he thought before shaking his head again. He must have hit it hard to be distracted in the middle of an emergency.

Where were the others? He glanced around again.

Ryla’c was a few yards away, groaning. Alive then. On the ground but moving towards his mother. Who wasn’t moving. Carter… on Jack’s other side, a purple cocoon started to open up. He blinked. A cocoon? Entrapta’s hair! She must have wrapped it around herself and Carter.

“Sir?” Carter was alive!

“Get out!” Jack snapped. “We need to evacuate the ship!” Where was Daniel? He had been further towards the front of the ship and… Jack steadied himself against the floor/wall and climbed towards the ship’s bridge. Just around a new corner in a formerly straight passage.

“Shit!”

Daniel was unconscious and had a metal rod sticking out of his back - he had been covering Sha’re with his body. Sha’re’s body, which still had a snake in it, Jack reminded himself. Daniel’s right leg also didn’t look good - what Jack could see of it; the lower half was buried under a piece of wall. Or floor. And behind him, Jack could see more people. In their underwear. They didn’t move, and he could see blood on several of them. All unconcious? Or stunned beforehand.

And the bridge… Jack gritted his teeth. Whatever had hit them had struck the bridge and caved it in. “Bra’Tac?” he called out, coughing again. The smoke was getting worse. Where was the old Jaffa? If he had been piloting this thing… Oh.

There was an arm on the floor. In a pool of blood. Sticking out from under a piece of stone that looked bigger than Jack’s first car and filled half the bridge’s remains. Jack could see the remains of a seat peeking out from under it as well. And more blood.

Fuck.

He couldn’t do anything for Bra’tac. And Daniel needed help. “Daniel’s wounded!” Jack managed to yell before coughing again.

Kneeling down - he almost lost his footing and slipped - he checked the wound. The metal had missed the spine. And the lung, since Daniel wasn't choking on his blood. And it hadn't gone straight through him.

But if Jack pulled it out, Daniel would likely bleed to death. Quickly. And Daniel's foot was a goner, too.

"Sir? We need to… Daniel!"

Carter had managed to reach him despite her disabled or broken shoulder.

"Careful," Jack said, "We need to transport him without making it worse. And Sha're."

"And the slaves," Carter added. "We took their places."

"Ah." That explained the unknown people.

"Entrapta!"

"Coming! Something's burning in the part we can't get to!"

Hair tentacles reached around the corner, followed by Entrapta. "Oh, no!" She rushed forward.

"Careful!" Jack said.

Hair wrapped around the metal stuck in his friend, and more tendrils slipped under the piece of the ship that was trapping Daniel's foot.

Jack heard a screeching sound, then the hair pulled Daniel away - and Jack had to wince at the sight of his mangled, bleeding foot. "Tourniquet!" he snapped. They needed to stop the bleeding.

Hair wrapped around the thigh while Jack pulled the belt off his stupid armour. A few seconds later, he had stopped the bleeding. But Daniel needed medical help, and quickly.

First, though, they needed to get out of this wreck. The smoke was getting worse, and Jack thought he saw something flicker behind the caved-in parts of the ship. Fire. Or shots from staff weapons - they were still surrounded by Serpent Guards.

Focus on the task at hand! He told himself. First, they needed to get out of this death trap. He could figure out how to escape the other death trap later.

"Move him to the rear. I'll get the others."

"What about Bra'tac?" Entrpata asked as she started to lift Daniel up.

She must have missed the arm. Jack shook his head. "He's dead."

Entrapta gasped. "But… Are you sure?"

"Yes. Move!"

They moved. Jack grabbed Sha're's body and followed them. Just at the corner, the ship suddenly shook again. He was pushed against the tilted wall, almost dropping Sha're, and banged his arm against some piece of broken crystal.

He glanced over his shoulder and cursed again - flames flickered behind him, and smoke started to fill the passage. The ship was burning up with them inside!

The slaves! For a moment, Jack considered going back for them. But he was already carrying Sha're, and with all the smoke… He wouldn't make it out again.

Cursing Apophis and himself, he hurried towards the back of the ship.

*****

There they came! Adora gritted her teeth, swatted a staff weapon bolt away with a flick of her wrist while she waited for another

second, then jumped. A volley of blasts passed below her, rising as the pilot of the first Death Glider tried to adjust his aim, but she was already too close, her blade swinging out before he could react.

She cut the craft in two, flipped and landed on the larger part, then pushed off it, launching herself towards the Death Glider's wingman.

The second fighter banked, but it was too slow and too late as well, and the tip of her blade slid into its right wing, then through it. The wing broke apart, and the Death Glider entered an uncontrolled spin just as the parts of the first hit the ground and exploded.

Adora dodged a falling piece of broken stone as large as Scorpia, swatted a twisted metal shard away, then flipped again. Arcing downward, she brought her sword down just before she hit the ground. The impact shattered the stone beneath her and sent out a shock wave that threw the dozen Jaffa around her into the air just as more stone fragments pelted the area.

She stood, then cut apart a staff cannon they had brought forward as she whirled - she had to…

She gasped. The Tel'tak was a wreck, half of its hull caved in - smashed - by the broken top of the palace. Her friends! Catra!

She raced back, smashing, cutting through a formation of Jaffa trying to rally, sending them flying with broken and bleeding bodies, until she reached the wreck. It was burning, and its left side had collapsed, tilting the whole thing to the side.

At the back of it, facing the hole she had cut into the palace wall, she could see Ryla'c struggling to drag his mother out of the wreck. But a dozen Serpent Guards were shooting at the wreck - and at the hole, where Glimmer tried to return fire with a staff.

Where were the others? Inside the palace? Or the wreck? Both? Where was Catra? If only Adora had her communicator!

“Adora!” Glimmer called out. “We’re pinned down here!”

And above them, the Ha’tak would soon be ready to blast the entire area. Apophis might hesitate to fire on his own palace… No, he wouldn’t. They had his queen, and the Serpent Guard were still firing on them.

Adora blocked a ragged volley from the Jaffa, then threw a piece of the palace that had fallen off the roof at them, scattering them. Then she used the sudden lull in the battle and rushed forward, grabbing Ryla’c and his unconscious mother, then leapt to Glimmer, putting the two down. Bow, sitting on the ground with a bandaged leg, slid over to them.

And Catra was there, firing a staff weapon down the hallway, supporting Teal’c, and… She was hurt! Blood was running down her side and leg!

“Catra!”

“I’m OK! Get the others before they burn!” Catra snapped.

She wasn’t OK! But Entrapta appeared in the back of the wrecked Te’tak, carrying Daniel - who had a metal shard sticking out of his back! And Sam was stumbling along. Where were Jack and Bra’tac?

No matter. Everyone was hurt. The Tel’tak was wrecked and burning. And they were surrounded by Jaffa, with a Ha’tak above them and Death Gliders rallying.

There was no choice. None at all. They were all going to die if she didn’t save them.

Adora raised her sword above her head and closed her eyes. Focused on her power. On her magic. Reached out for that particular pattern and opened herself to the magic.

She connected, hissing through clenched teeth as she became a conduit for magic. For power. Felt as if she was about to burst as

the planet's magic filled her. Pushing her. Straining her.

Then she cut the pattern, and the world turned white as the magic was released.

The pressure vanished - but she was still blazing with power. She looked up at the hovering Ha'tak. She could destroy it utterly. She just had to slash her sword at it and let her power go.

And she wanted to do it. Destroy it. And the Serpent Guards. Everyone who had hurt her friends.

But that wouldn't save her friends. Wouldn't save Catra.

Adora clenched her teeth and stepped out of the palace. She was going to save her friends. Catra. Everyone.

A few Jaffa were firing at her, but the bolts didn't reach her - her aura stopped them. They didn't matter.

Entrapta was calling out to her, and she could see Jack behind Sam, almost at the heck of the Tel'tak.

She didn't listen to what they were saying. She couldn't spare the attention. Not with all the power filling her, almost overwhelming her.

She focused, took a deep, shivering breath - and released her magic.

And, once more, the entire area was bathed in white light. In She-Ra's magic.

Next to her, Glimmer gasped and shuddered. "Adora…"

Adora looked around. A bit away, a group of Jaffa in broken armour were on the ground, staring at her with wide eyes. Another dropped the weapon he had been firing at her and staggered back, stumbling over a Jaffa who was sitting up with a dazed expression and flexing his fingers.

No one was firing any more, she realised. Everyone was staring. Gaping. But that wouldn't last.

It didn't have to, though - everyone was gathering around her. Catra, Glimmer, Bow, Entrapta, Sam, Jack, Daniel, Sha're - still stunned, she noted. Weird. Teal'c and his family. "Bra'tac?" she asked, dreading the answer.

Jack shook his head.

No! Adora pressed her lips together. She had failed. But she wouldn't fail the others.

"Glimmer! Teleport us to the Stargate!"

*****

Teleport? That would take a while. Catra and Teal'c first, to start taking over the Stargate's control room, followed by the wounded - the civilians, all wounded had been healed - while She-Ra guarded the rest. Or attempted to.

Samantha Carter glanced around, zat'nik'tel in hand. Any moment, the Serpent Guards would overcome their shock and resume fighting. Or the Ha'tak above them would start firing at them. Apophis might be too intrigued by the display of magic to order a bombardment, or he might decide that even destroying his palace was worth it to kill them.

But Glimmer yelled: "Entrapta, grab everyone!", and Sam felt hair wrap around her thigh.

A moment later, she appeared next to the D.H.D. of Saqarra's Stargate in a shower of sparks. With everyone else.

One Serpent Guard shouted an alert, raising his staff weapon, but Adora laid him out with a kick while Catra pounced on the next, and everyone else started firing. Sam stunned the official trying to flee, then crouched down. They had to deal with the guards behind the reinforced walls, and…

Glimmer reappeared in front of her, panting. And the Colonel and Catra were missing. No, not missing - Sam saw flashes behind the firing positions in the walls.

"Everyone behind me!" Adora yelled, her sword changing into a huge shield, covering the group as they backed up to a wall. Several staff weapon blasts hit the shield or the wall next to them as the concealed guards tried to kill them, but it didn't take long for Catra and the Colonel to silence the weapons.

"Dial to the rally spot!" Glimmer snapped, still breathing heavily.

She must have severely strained herself teleporting everyone at once - and then following up with teleporting the Colonel and Catra. Sam hadn't even known that Glimmer could do that. Was it a result of the restoration of magic to the planet? A temporary boost?

Questions for another time, Sam reminded herself as she dialled PK-Z642's gate address. They had to escape and recover.

The Stargate spun, chevrons locking, as the Colonel and Catra returned. "I bet Apophis is currently cursing himself for burying his Stargate so deeply that he can't reach us," the Colonel said with a grin.

"We don't know if he is present," Sam reminded him.

"I doubt that the Serpent Guards would have risked killing Amaunet without his direct command," Teal'c said. He was standing next to his family, but his staff weapon was pointed at the main gate to the room.

He had a point, though Sam was sure the analysts back on Earth would go over it with a fine comb. Too bad they didn't have combat footage to dissect. The sensor readings from Entrapta's tool were rather limited. But they did have several scans and data from the security system of his palace, which might contain valuable intel.

The wormhole stabilised.

"Alright! Everyone through the gate!" The Colonel gestured to the ramp. "It's time to go home!"

*****

Gate Area, PK-Z642, November 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter dialled home to Earth the moment the wormhole collapsed. The sooner they were off this planet and back home, the better. They had already lost Bra'tac and narrowly escaped being killed themselves. If the broken tip of the palace that had crushed the Tel'tak's side had fallen slightly to the right…

Sam closed her eyes for a moment as the Stargate dialled. This had been too close for comfort. Far too close. Still, while it had cost them, dearly, they had achieved their objectives. However, she was well aware that the brass back home would not be pleased with the results. Bra'tac's death wouldn't be an issue. Soldiers risked their lives on every mission, in every battle. But the potential discovery of the Etherians and the return of magic - to a planet held by Apophis… that would cause more than some ruffled feathers amongst the Alliance. Pointed questions would be the least they could expect. And quite justified questions, Sam had to admit.

And yet, when she glanced at Teal'c, who was talking in a low voice with his family, and at Daniel standing next to Sha're's body, which was still carried by Entrapta, she couldn't help feeling that it had been worth it.

*****

The Rescue Operation Part 5

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 10th, 1999

Catra wasn't fond of debriefings. She knew how essential they were to properly wage war, to spot mistakes for corrections and improvements, to collect intel to pursue, and to evaluate officers, but unless she was the one running the debriefing, she couldn't help remembering how Shadow Weaver had always used them to put her down and manipulate her - and Adora.

And she wasn't in charge of this debriefing. So, she had to listen to someone else list everything that had gone wrong during the mission. And to make it even worse, it wasn't even Adora but some paper-pushing officers from Earth who had never done anything like infiltrating an enemy stronghold to spring a prisoner and do some sabotage while you were there.

She glanced at Adora. As Supreme Commander of the Alliance, she could take over any time she wanted. But her lover just sat there, straight and tense, as the idiot in front of the room, Admiral Kearsy, droned on.

"...and then, having narrowly escaped and commandeered an FTL-capable vessel, you decided to infiltrate the palace again instead of withdrawing.."

"Yes," Adora replied, nodding. "We don't leave anyone behind."

"Like the Marines," Catra added just when he was about to go on and flashed her teeth,

The admiral frowned briefly at that. She couldn't tell if that was because he didn't like the Marines - he was from the United States Navy and, as Jack had explained, the different branches of their mess of an armed force hated each other - or because he didn't like being interrupted. Probably both.

"Ah, yes. In any case, you decided to ambush a worker crew and impersonate them to infiltrate the palace - which, at this point, was on full alert with all checkpoints manned."

"Yes," Adora replied again.

"We counted on the Goa'uld and Jaffa arrogance to ignore their slaves, but we were prepared for being discovered," Glimmer cut in. She didn't like the briefing either - Catra could tell that she was struggling with her temper.

"Your alternative plan consisted of fighting through the Serpent Guards until you reached the palace dungeons." Kearsy didn't roll his eyes, but he made clear what he thought of that without saying so.

"Yes," Adora replied once more, and Catra smirked when her lover's earnest expression made the admiral blink.

"A perfectly reasonable plan," O'Neill said - he wasn't quite slouching in his seat, but he was a bit too obviously relaxed for the briefing. "We fought our way out, after all."

"While losing the ship you had taken, General O'Neill. And being forced to not only reveal magic to the Goa'uld but also activate the planet's magic!" Kearsy glowered at them.

"And losing Bra'tac, a valued ally and friend," Adora said with a frown.

Disappointingly, the admiral was smart enough not to openly dismiss Bra'tac's death as an acceptable loss. He nodded. "Yes, of course."

Catra was still dead certain that he didn't really care about Bra'tac. Even though the Jaffa had been Apophis's Prime for decades and had known both the Goa'uld and, even more importantly, Apophis's key Jaffa subordinates better than almost anyone else. His death was, even seen from a rather cold military view, a heavy loss. But they already knew that, and mentioning it

to yank Kearsy's chain wouldn't be worth making Adora feel guilty again. So she shrugged. "Anyway, our plan worked - the Jaffa were too arrogant to check all workers."

"But you took a considerable risk," Kearsy insisted.

"It was a calculated risk," Glimmer retorted. "And we would do the same thing again. We don't leave anyone behind."

"Yes," Adora firmly agreed.

"Though next time, we'll have better gear," Entrapta added. "Concealed weapons and communicators, shield generators that can be dismantled and hidden, stealth bots to carry gear and support us, maybe holographic projectors so we can wear armour and look harmless… there's so much we can do to make the next mission easier!"

A bunch of stealth bots to serve as a distraction or additional forces would have come in handy, though that ran the risk of having the enemy salvage their technology. Catra made a note to bring that up at the next planning meeting with SG-1 - or whatever they were called now. Not that Catra cared too much about official titles. Even Sam slipped from time to time and talked about 'the Colonel' despite O'Neill's promotion.

"And we have to interrogate Amaunet," O'Neill added. "As soon as the Tok'ra can get her out of Sha're. As Apophi's queen, she should know a lot about his realm. And, as a backstabbing snake, I am sure she'll be willing to sell him out."

"And the loss of his queen will weaken Apophis long-term," Sam said. "He needs her to replace the Prim'ta in his warriors. That can be compensated to some degree by prioritising who gets one, albeit with the risk of alienating those who would be shortened," she amended.

Catra nodded. Without a queen, Apophis would run out of larvae, but that would take years to take effect - in the best case. But it

was a hit to Apophis's prestige, and if that information spread, he would look vulnerable to his rivals.

"Nevertheless, the enemy is now aware of both magic and Etheria," Kearsy repeated himself.

"We can't assume that," O'Neill retorted. "They saw magic - but will they recognise it? Or think that was just advanced technology?" He grinned. "Hard to tell the difference."

"Technically, magic is a form of advanced technology," Entrapta piped up. "But I think you mean the specific form of magic, right?"

"Yes," Kearsy said, frowning some more.

"And the Jaffa who witnessed this might simply consider this a demonstration of divine power," Sam pointed out. "They were indoctrinated to see the Goa'uld as gods and their technology as divine powers, so they are likely to interpret She-Ra's demonstration similarly."

"And Apophis might do the same," O'Neill added. "He might suspect rivals - or other alien species - behind this, using advanced technology."

"Nevertheless, we cannot assume so," Kearsy insisted. "We must consider that our most secret advantages have been revealed to the enemy!"

"The Tok'ra will look into it," Adora said. "We should know more about this soon."

Catra hoped so. Out loud, she said: "So, no point in doomsaying yet. Who knows, Adora healing everyone might even convert more Jaffa to her worship.

Adora and Kearsy glared at her for that comment. She counted it as a successful debriefing.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, November 11th, 1999

"...and at that point, we withdrew through the portal." Jack O'Neill finished. On the holoprojection next to him, the figures representing their group finished moving through the gate and vanished, leaving the 3D projection of Apophis's gate room empty.

He took a step forward and fell into a comfortable parade rest as he faced the officers and selected troops attending this meeting. Most of them were still staring at the projection that Entrapta had configured based on the readings from her multitool. Ah, if Stargate Command had had such technology before they met the Etherians…

But a few - more than Jack was comfortable with - were staring at him as if he had just single-handedly kicked Apophis's butt and won the war or something. He hadn't seen that kind of hero worship back at Stargate Command; everyone had been used to SG-1's mission. At least the older hands. And the newbies generally were too shocked by the news that aliens were real to gawk at SG-1.

Anyway, his troops here would grow out of it once they had a few missions under their belts themselves. It was time to get down to business. "So, what do we learn from this?" he asked.

"She-Ra saved the day?" Kelly asked with a wide grin.

Jack chuckled. Leave it to SAS to be the first to dare to crack a joke. "That's one lesson. But what does that mean in more detail?"

Isa rose to answer, then sat down when she realised that she was blocking the line of sight for a bunch of soldiers sitting behind her. "It means that we need to bring more firepower on such missions if we can't have She-Ra with us."

Campbell, sitting next to her, added: "And we need to take magic respectively its absence into account when planning such

missions. We can't teleport."

Jack nodded. "Yes. Unless we drag our Supreme Commander and Queen Glimmer with us on every mission, we can't repeat that. And restoring a planet's magic is a two-edged sword."

Jones, the former SEAL, frowned. "We'll have to expect Apophis to start using magic against us - at least on his capital."

A number of the troopers looked wary at that. Jack smiled and shook his head. "Oh, he might have some magitech stuff lying around from before magic was sealed away, and that might surprise us, but Apophis can't just snap his fingers and have trained sorceresses at his beck and call - believe me, I know that. And if we return to Saqqara, we will do so with as many princesses and sorceresses as possible." That planet was now one where their powers worked from the start, unlike pretty much every other planet in the Goa'uld Empire.

That seemed to calm down the soldiers. But Jack knew that most of them wouldn't admit if they were concerned. He would joke about it himself, in their place. "What else can we learn from this?"

"That Apophis's forces are - or were - vulnerable to infiltration tactics," another officer, Lt. Fournier, said. "Though they are likely to adjust their procedures after this."

"Yes. We can't count on them falling for the same ploy again. But we can count on Apophis purging his guards for their failure," Jack said. "So, his forces will lose a lot of experience and cohesion." Like Stalin's purges wrecked the Red Army.

"And we need better kit if we're supposed to do such missions," Burke commented from the back. "I would rather not run around in looted rags and hope to take an enemy weapon before I can fight."

"I'll pass it on to Q," Kelly joked.

"We've already done that," Jack said with a grin. Try to be a wiseass, hm? "We should have some specialised gear if we have to infiltrate a place again - though, as was pointed out" - he nodded at Fournier - "we can't count on the Goa'uld remaining stupid about that." As Apophis had just proven, they did learn from their mistakes. The snake's traps had almost gotten them. "But for now, let's focus on less undercover work and more on traditional infiltration tactics. How do we assault such a complex with our forces? How do we get inside, get our target, and something very important: how do we get out again? Without a stealth shuttle or the fleet picking us up."

Campbell closed his mouth, Jack noted.

"We need breaching charges, lots of them," Jones said.

"Electronic warfare specialists to hack the security systems so we can sneak inside," Kelly countered.

"A few manpads to keep the airspace contested," Müller, former GSG-9, said.

More and more joined the discussion.

"Distractions - drones and bots."

"Rappelling gear."

"Those hover sledges."

"Some sort of active camouflage."

Jack nodded while his aide noted all the proposals, projecting them onto the screen behind him. Yeah, this would be a productive session; he could tell.

*****

P34-353J, November 13th, 1999, (Earth Time)

Watching the preparations of the Tok'ra, Adora couldn't help fidgeting. There was a chance that this would go wrong. Aumanet might kill Sha're before the Tok'ra could extract her. And even if Adora restored magic to the world, she might not be fast enough to save Sha're. As she had been told, she might not be fast enough even if she had Magic restored beforehand.

And the Tok'ra didn't want magic restored to this world. Not yet, according to Anise, but that might be wishful thinking according to Sam - their friend apparently couldn't wait to begin experimenting with magic.

She glanced at Daniel, who hadn't taken his eyes off Sha're since they had arrived on this world. If the worst happened, after all they had gone through, after everything they had done to save Sha're… Adora knew how that felt. When she had seen Catra fall on Horde Prime's flagship, had held her body… No one should go through that. No one would if she could help it.

But she couldn't always help it. She could only try her best, always. And she would.

She shook her head, trying to banish the gloomy thoughts. Things would go well. They had to. The Tok'ra had done this before, many times. They had saved Lieutenant Lenkova as well.

Remembering that also reminded Adora of how the woman had been affected by a relatively short possession. Sha're had been possessed for over two years. The horrors she must have gone through… Adora hadn't suffered like that, but others had. Catra, for one - her lover was staring at Sha're with a fixed expression. And she was far from the only one who had been mind-controlled by Horde Prime.

Maybe she should offer Daniel and Sha're to spend some time on Etheria to recover? They didn't have trained therapists like Earth had, not yet - although they were working on that - but they had experience with this situation. It couldn't hurt, at least, in Adora's opinion.

On the other hand, Sha’re had never seen Earth, Daniel’s home. She might want to get used to Earth first. Or go home to Abydos - though that would have to wait until they unburied their Stargate again. They could send a ship there, but that would take a long time… maybe once the spy bot network reached the planet, they could install a better system to protect the gate against invasions, and they could resume regular contact…

It wasn’t up to her, anyway, Adora reminded herself. That was the decision of the Abydonians. And to Sha’re and Daniel. They might just want to return to Abydos and resume their lives there. Though Skaara was still possessed by Klorel, so Daniel wouldn’t want to abandon him, would he? And neither would Sha’re abandon her brother. Or…

“They’re about to start,” Catra whispered.

“Oh.” Adora flushed a little. She had been so absorbed by her own thoughts, she had almost missed it.

The extractor started to humm, and a beam appeared, striking Sha’re. Adora clenched her teeth. This was it. If things went wrong…

But Anise, who was operating the extractor, seemed neither worried nor alarmed as the extraction continued. That must be a good sign.

She still fidgeted. Not as much as Daniel, though, who was trembling as he watched and waited.

“It’ll be alright,” Jack told him in a low voice, putting his hand on his friend’s shoulder. Sam said something in a whisper that Adora didn’t catch.

Daniel nodded, but Adora wasn’t sure he had heard either of them. Adora could understand that.

Then the extractor beeped, and she could see a symbiont - Aumanet - wriggle inside it. And Sha’re… was breathing. Adora

could see her chest rise and fall.

"The extraction was a success," Anise announced. "I'm administering the counteragent to the sedative now." She bent down and used an injector on Sha're's arm. "She should wake up soon. However, she was possessed by the Goa'uld for a long time..." Anise trailed off as Daniel stepped past her to stand at Sha're's side.

A minute passed. Was something wrong? Lenkova had woken up more quickly. Maybe the time spent possessed played a role…

A slight gasp interrupted her. Sha're opened her eyes, breathing heavily, looking around wildly.

Right. Adora bit her lower lip. The last thing Sha're would remember was being attacked by unknown women in Apophis's harem.

"Sha're…" Daniel bent forward. He was smiling and crying at the same time. "It's OK. You're safe. You're *free*."

"D-Daniel…" Sha're reached up to him, one trembling hand touching his cheek. "You're…"

He gently held it. "I'm here."

Then she started sobbing, and the two hugged each other, both crying and mumbling.

Adora pressed her lips together and blinked to clear her own eyes. Maybe they should leave? This felt like a very private moment. On the other hand, this wasn't their home, and if they needed help…

She glanced at Jack and Sam, who stood there, smiling at the couple. If they didn't see a need to leave, then it was probably OK.

No one was saying anything. Not even Anise. The two probably didn't really notice anyone right now.

And while Daniel and Sha’re kept holding each other, Adora reached out to grab and squeeze Catra’s hand. Her lover looked startled for a moment, then smiled at her.

*****

Samantha Carter had spent years ensuring that she wasn’t seen as ‘emotional’. That would have been, if not a death sentence, then at least very damaging to her career in the Air Force. She was aware that a lot of sexist officers would have jumped at the chance to cast doubts on her ability to handle the stress of combat and leadership. Even after she had established herself as the leading scientist of Stargate Command and an essential member of SG-1, she had kept any public display of emotions to a minimum.

But she couldn’t help the tears in her eyes when she saw Daniel embrace Sha’re, both crying. After all the suffering, all the danger, they were finally reunited. Safe. She took a deep breath and glanced at the Colonel - the General, she corrected herself once again. His eyes were suspiciously wet as well. She was tempted to tell him that she wouldn’t tell if he didn’t, but that would be crossing a line she had kept away from for a long time.

Instead, she cleared her throat. “Maybe we should give them some privacy?” The middle of a Tok’ra extraction chamber wasn’t the best place for an emotional reunion.

“Right,” the General agreed. He still hesitated a moment, though, before addressing the couple. “Hey… we’ve got a room prepared for you to, ah, recover.”

The Tok’ra had, Sam thought. They had done this before, numerous times.

It took a second before Daniel turned his head toward them. “Ah…” Then he looked at Sha’re, pulling back a bit with obvious reluctance before he seemed to remember where they were. “I think that’s a good idea…”

Sha’re also looked around. Her eyes widened when she saw Adora and Catra.

Adora beamed at her. “Hello! I’m Adora - or She-Ra when I am like this.” She waved a hand in front of her chest.

Catra rolled her eyes at that but nodded at Sha’re. “Catra.”

“I remember you.” Sha’re nodded. “You saved me?”

“We all did,” Adora said at once. “We’re Daniel’s friends. And we’d like to be your friends as well.”

“Thank you.” Sha’re nodded again. She hadn’t let go of Daniel, still clutching his shirt with both hands. Nor had she wiped the tears off her cheeks. She turned to nod at Sam and the General as well. “Thank you.”

Then she spotted the container with Aumanet inside and froze.

“She’s our prisoner,” Adora told her. “She won’t ever hurt you again.”

Sam half-expected Sha’re to demand the Goa’uld’s death - she would have, in her place - but the woman slowly nodded, trembling slightly. “I would like to leave this room,” she whispered.

Anise - no, Freya, the voice was hers - nodded. “Please follow me.” She gestured to the side, where a door opened, revealing a room with a large bed and other amenities. “Simply call for someone if you need anything.”

Daniel slowly stood, helping Sha’re up, and the two, holding hands, stepped into the room.

Sam sighed as the door closed behind them.

“She’ll need time to get over her ordeal,” Anise stated the obvious.

Everyone nodded at that quite solemnly without saying anything. Not even Catra or the General.

Instead, he looked at the captured Goa'uld queen. "So… I guess we'll add another snake to our aquarium."

"We would like to be present for her interrogation," Anise said. It sounded more like a demand than a request, in Sam's opinion. Then again, she knew that the Tok'ra were not entirely happy about the mission to Saqqara. The purges Apophis was conducting would endanger their agents at his court.

"Of course." Adora smiled at her.

Ansie looked surprised for a moment. She might not have realised that Adora was the genuine article, as the Colonel - the General - would say. Honest, open and idealistic. Even more so than most other Etherians they knew.

"Your knowledge of Apophis's court will be useful for that," Catra added.

"Yes." Anise took the container with Amaunet and handed it over to Adora before turning to Sam. "Would you like to see my latest work while we await your return to Earth?"

While they waited for Daniel and Sha're to recover enough to travel back, in other words. Sam nodded.

"No blowing up the planet," the General called out as they left.

"Yes, sir."

Outside in the hallway, on the way to Anise's lab, Freya asked: "How is Entrapta doing? I would have expected her to come with you for this. She wasn't hurt, was she?"

Sam sighed softly. "She's very busy researching and developing tools and weapons more suitable for similar missions."

Anise raised her eyebrows. “We have significant experience with such missions.”

“She wants to ensure that we won’t lose anyone else on the next mission,” Sam said, skirting the implied question. Entrapta hadn’t taken Bra’tac’s death well. Sam wasn’t even sure that her friend didn’t still hold out hope that Bra’tac might have survived, just like Entrapta had when she was thought dead during Glimmer and Bow’s rescue from the Fright Zone. Not that she would say that, of course - that was Entrapta’s business.

Anise might suspect it, anyway - she nodded. “Ah.”

The Tok’ra also had significant experience with losing friends on such missions, Sam reminded herself. Anise might even know better than Sam what Entrapta was feeling right now.

And while it was completely unreasonable, petty and likely unfounded, Sam couldn’t help feeling a bit envious.

*****

Thule Air Force Base, Greenland, Earth, November 14th, 1999

Another day in the Earth Kingdom of Ice and Snow. Catra shuddered at the thought of the temperature outside. Her fur wouldn’t do a thing against the cold out there. At least they could stick to the base this time since they hadn’t taken Frosta with them, so no one had to go outside and tell the princess that landing strips weren’t playgrounds to be filled with ice sculptures.

On the other hand, watching the locals react to Adora carrying the new ‘snake tank’ inside was amusing. The soldiers in the base seemed both surprised that she could carry the thing at all without any help and annoyed somehow that the Supreme Commander of the Alliance was doing ‘menial work’, as one of the officers had told another in a whisper they thought Catra’s ears wouldn’t pick up after Adora had refused to let them help.

As if they could actually carry the thing! However, as funny as it was to see Earth troops still being surprised at seeing senior officers who actually did more than merely leading from the back, it was also a symptom of a potential problem. The Alliance leadership had grudgingly accepted that Adora and the other princesses would be on the frontlines 'whenever necessary', and Jack had extended that to himself somehow, but it was still a tenuous thing. And if it became the norm… Earth officers weren't princesses. Or Catra. Jack was great in a fight, sure, but she didn't think every Earth general would do more good fighting in the trenches than at the planning table. And if Earth officers started thinking that to get promoted in the Alliance, they had to follow his example…

She winced at the thought. That was a good way to kill off experienced leaders. An acceptable trade-off if they were after your position and willing to stab you in the back - literally in some cases - since fighting a coup in the middle of a war was worse than having to replace a Force Captain and recover from a lost offensive. But the Alliance was still struggling with training troops to fight a war in space and on other worlds, and losing any officer with experience or talent would hurt that.

But, she thought as she glanced at Adora while they waited in the cargo lift taking them down, trying to explain that to her friends would be a challenge. Adora had been raised in the Horde, but she had fought for years in the Princess Alliance. And all the others had grown up there. Except for Scorpia, but… she could shrug off cannon shots and throw tanks around, so she would probably take a while to understand the problem.

Maybe she should talk with Jack about that. At the very least, it should be amusing to see if he could think of a solution that would allow him to keep fighting on the front and prevent others from following his example.

The lift stopped, and the doors parted - they were on the special prisoner level. Catra straightened. Time to focus on the task at

hand. She could deal with the military culture clash later. Maybe when Daniel was back at work - cultures were his thing.

“Hi!” Adora called out when they had passed through security and entered the holding area. “How are you doing?”

Osiris and Seth ignored her greeting, staring at the tank she was holding.

“That’s Aumanet,” Catra told them. “Apophis queen.”

Both jerked at that, their little heads twisting.

“A queen?” Osiris’s synthetic voice asked.

“Apophis’s queen?” Seth added.

“We sneaked into his harem and took her since she was using the body of a friend,” Catra said. Aumanet would tell them the story anyway once they finished interrogating her and allowed her to talk to her fellow prisoners. This was merely to show her that she wouldn’t be killed after talking.

Both Goa’ld laughed at that, the translator turning their hissing into synthetic laughter. They would probably be more amused if they heard about how close the whole mission had come to failing, but since Amaunet didn’t know that, having been stunned for the entire duration of that part, they didn’t need to know.

Wouldn’t want them to get ideas.

“And what about Apophis?” Seth asked.

“He wasn’t in the harem,” Adora said. “We just came for his queen and his prisoners.”

“Was she his only queen?” Osiris still eyed the other snake.

“As far as we know, yes,” Adora said. And the Tok’ra knew a lot. Though if Apophis had a replacement for Aumanet waiting, he

probably would have kept that a secret from almost everyone - including Aumanet.

“Anyway,” Catra spoke up. “We’re just showing Aumanet where she’ll be living afterwards.”

“Yes.” Adora proceeded to show the snake the third habitat in the tract. “We’ll be back later.”

“I’m looking forward to it,” Osiris said.

“It will be good being able to hold a decent conversation again,” Seth added.

Both were bickering when Adora and Catra left the cell tract and headed to the interrogation rooms. Which was a good thing. If their prisoners started cooperating, gathering intel from them would become harder.

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“Apophis will conquer your world, and you will pay for your crimes against your gods, Tau’ri.”

Jack O’Neill had met Goa’uld before and knew how arrogant they were, and this snake queen was a contender for the top position. She was a prisoner of war who had been captured in the palace of Apophis, on his throne world, and she still acted as if she was in charge. He shrugged as casually as he could. “He tried before and failed.”

“That was because he was betrayed from within and underestimated you. He will not make these mistakes again.” The synthetic voice from Entrapta’s snake tank interface didn’t sound as creepy as the actual Goa’uld voice. That robbed Amaunet’s boasts of any weight they might have left, in Jack’s opinion. In fact, she sounded almost like a complaining kid.

“Well, we’re looking forward to seeing what new mistakes he’ll make,” he said, grinning.

"I am looking forward to seeing how he will punish you for your insolence," she retorted. "He has kept some of his enemies alive for years, suffering unimaginable agonies, until he granted them the mercy of death."

Now, *that* was a threat if you knew Apophis. Which Jack did. And yet… the snake queen hadn't mentioned how *she* would take revenge on them so far. Was she planning to offer them mercy if they let her go or something? It wasn't the best plan, far from it, but better, at least a little bit, than trying to threaten them with Apophis's revenge. That had such a vibe of 'my daddy can beat you all up', Jack almost laughed out loud at the mental picture it evoked.

"You know, that would sound more impressive if we hadn't just walked into Apophis's palace and captured you, liberated his prisoners, and then walked out again," Catra cut in. She leaned back and stretched her arms over her head. "Apophis just doesn't sound that dangerous to me."

"I see no proof for your claims," the snake said.

"Other than the fact that you are our prisoner?" Jack raised his eyebrows at her.

"We obviously captured you and got away," Adora spoke up. "You know that."

Amaunet didn't respond to that. "Apophis knows you have me. And he will come for me with all his might. You cannot stand against his fleets. Your only hope is to beg for mercy for your world lest he burns it down for your crimes against your god."

And here came the pitch. Jack shook his head. "No, thank you. I think we're doing fine." He was tempted to tell her about their guard fleet, but that would have given the snake intel, and it was too early for such a ploy. And it was a Horde fleet, so boasting of its power kind of felt like Amaunet threatening them with Daddy Apophis's revenge.

“Your arrogance will be your downfall! You cannot stand against the might of your gods!”

Jack had to chuckle at the irony of a Goa’uld calling them out for being arrogant. He heard Catra snort as well. Unfortunately, the snake’s face wasn’t exactly very expressive, so he couldn’t tell how she took that.

Adora cleared her throat. “I disagree. We can and will stand against you.”

“You think your new allies will protect you?” Amaunet’s synthetic voice made a scoffing noise. “If they were powerful enough to be a concern, they wouldn’t have hidden from us like rats.”

She probably assumed that they were allied with cat people like Catra. It was an understandable assumption, given her knowledge.

And Catra laughed again. “We weren’t hiding from you - we were busy fighting an enemy a bit more impressive than the Goa’uld. But with them defeated…” She shrugged. “We might as well take care of you.”

“Words are cheap. I see only you here and no one else but Tau’ri.”

“Then you are blind,” Martouf spoke up.

Hearing the snake voice made Amaunet jerk in her tank. “Traitor!”

“You cannot betray whom you never owed allegiance to,” Martouf replied.

“That’s how you did it! You were let into the palace by a traitor! Who are you? Kabesh? Horon?”

Jack filed the two names away. Suspected traitors in Apophis’s court were potential turncoats.

Catra snorted again. “You still don’t understand what you are facing.”

“We aren’t Goa’uld,” Martouf said.

“Tok’ra!” Somehow, the synthetic voice managed to hiss.

“Yes.” Martouf stared at her. “We would have killed you after freeing your host. But others stayed our hand.”

The glance at Adora was perhaps a bit much, in Jack’s opinion. But they had to convince Amaunet that she was in the hands of a powerful enemy and that cooperation was her best bet to survive. “Osiris and Seth cooperated,” he said.

“Traitors!”

“Realists.” Priest stepped into the snake’s field of view.

And Amaunet recoiled. “Horde!”

So, she was familiar enough with Horde Prime to recognise his clones. Another bit of useful information.

“False goddess,” Priest retorted with a sneer. “You think you can stand against our fleets? The only reason we have not yet burned down your worlds and wiped you out is that our leader is more merciful than Horde Prime was.”

Jack couldn’t help wondering if Priest wasn’t acting but merely telling the truth.

“Horde Prime is dead?” Amaunet asked.

“Her Divine Highness destroyed the Great Deceiver and freed us!” Priest bowed towards Adora. “Her wisdom and mercy have guided us ever since.”

Adora smiled a bit weakly, but Jack doubted that the snake queen noticed - she was twitching in the tank.

Well, it seemed that they had softened her up enough for the interrogators waiting outside to take over.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, November 15th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and while the interrogations have just started, we're optimistic that Aumanet can be convinced to cooperate, at least to the degree Osiris and Seth are cooperating with us," Adora summed up. The Goa'uld queen certainly had been impressed once she had realised that she wasn't just facing Earth but the Horde.

"Which isn't much," Mermista commented. "They are still trying to manipulate us in the hope of gaining power for themselves."

Adora nodded. "But they are doing so by trying to ingratiate themselves to us, which means they are helping us."

"And trying to set up their inevitable betrayal," Mermista retorted.

"Of course they are." Glimmer snorted. "But we know that. And forewarned is forearmed."

"And without sapient hosts, they aren't at their best," Catra added. "They have all their memories, but they aren't as smart as they think they are. And that makes them vulnerable."

Perfuma frowned at that. "I still think that's cruel. Leaving them in such a diminished state… It's wrong."

"Letting them possess someone would also be wrong," Glimmer retorted. "No one deserves to be a prisoner in their own body."

Everyone nodded at that. Especially those who had been controlled by Horde Prime back in the war. Adora reached over and patted Catra's thigh.

Her lover snorted softly, with a twisted grin, but put her own hand over Adora's.

"I know!" Perfuma sighed, nibbling on her lower lip. "But isn't there a way we can help them without hurting anyone else? We've managed to create synthetic symbionts so the Jaffa won't have to depend on the Goa'uld larvae any more."

"It's a bit harder to create a synthetic host," Bow said. "Especially since they would have to be sapient to provide the Goa'uld with the boost in intelligence they are used to. And if they're sapient, they are people."

"And no one should be controlled by Goa'uld," Mermista added.

Not even criminals. Adora nodded.

"Where's Entrapta, anyway?" Netossa asked.

"She's busy in her lab," Adora told her. Their friend had been busy since they had returned from Saqqara. And that was worrying. She really needed to talk to Entrapta about this. As soon as this meeting was done. Well, this and the one after it.

"A sort of synthetic host would help the Tok'ra, too, wouldn't it?" Frosta asked.

Adora wasn't sure about that. "I think they want equal partners for their hosts, not some, uh, biological bot." Which was a kind of worrying concept to begin with.

"Yes," Perfuma said. "A true symbiosis, where both parts profit and the whole is greater than the sum of its parts."

"People aren't plants," Mermista said.

"Of course, they aren't," Perfuma said, frowning a little. "But the principles here are the same."

“Yes,” Scorpia spoke up with a smile. “And even if it doesn’t help the Tok’ra, if the Goauld won’t need people as hosts any more, that’s good.”

Frosta scoffed. “They are parasites. Why should we help them get smarter? That will only make them more dangerous.”

“Because we can’t have peace with them if they feel that they have to possess others just to be as smart as they are used to,” Perfuma told her. “We need to offer them an alternative that allows them to live peacefully with everyone else.”

“But with their genetic memory, they also feel that they need to be worshipped and rule over others,” Netossa pointed out. “At least the majority of them - I am aware that some of them joined the Tok’ra.”

“Yes,” Adora said. “Even Goa’uld can change.”

“Some of them,” Catra commented. “Most of them won’t.”

Frosta frowned at her, Adora noted, but seemed to agree.

“And editing their genetic memory would make us as bad as Horde Prime,” Bow said. Everyone looked at him. “Ah, just pointing out that that’s not a solution,” he said, smiling weakly.

Adora wasn’t sure if anyone had brought that up so far, but it was clear that Bow had thought about it. But he was right. “Yes. We won’t stoop to that level. To manipulate people like that…” She almost shuddered at the thought.

“And what if the Goa’uld won’t accept peace? Mermista asked.

“Then we banish them to their homeworld and blockade it,” Glimmer said.

“Or we simply capture all queens and don’t let them spawn more of them,” Frosta suggested. “Then they will die out. Peacefully,” she added when everyone stared at her.

“That is wrong as well. To keep them from procreating... We would doom an entire species!” Perfuma shook her head. “We can’t do that!”

“They wouldn’t die out - the Tok’ra would survive,” Frosta defended her idea.

“The Tok’ra don’t consider themselves Goa’uld,” Adora pointed out.

“Biologically, they are the same species unless you consider their genetic memory as enough of a difference to treat them as two species,” Bow said.

That sounded like a technicality. “We’re not going to wipe out the Goa’uld,” Adora said.

“Then we’ll have to lobotomise them and lock them up in their native swamp,” Catra said. She didn’t seem to be sad about that, Adora noted.

And she wasn’t alone with that stance in the Princess Alliance, judging by the nods from others.

It still felt wrong to do that to anyone. But unless someone came up with a better idea, it might be the least wrong solution the Alliance had.

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The Rescue Operation Part 6

Royal Laboratory, Dryl, November 15th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"..and this is a modular blast weapon - it's not quite as powerful as a staff weapon, but it can be hitched up to any stabilising component, such as a staff or even a broom, and will work as one. And this is a modular zat'nik'tel, which will separate into five components that can be hidden more easily and shouldn't show up on scans. At least not on scans with known Goa'uld technology. I had to redesign the trigger array to make it work, and the frame, but the latter was evident from the start, and it should work like a zat. And this is…"

Samantha Carter had to suppress a wince while watching Entrapta present the results of her recent work. Her friend had been… 'productive' was one description. 'Manic' was another. Both fit.

She glanced at the butler waiting in the wings. Wasn't watching out for Entrapta's health one of his duties? On the other hand, how much could a butler on Etheria do if their princess was set on something?

"...so, with just a few twists, we can have an antenna that will connect to the pocket multitool and increase the scanner's range by one hundred per cent - I wanted a greater increase, but that fried the test bot's matrix when it was used when worn, so I think it wouldn't be healthy to use as a human, though I haven't tested that."

Sam felt both relieved and even more concerned after hearing that.

"Anyway! I was mostly working with Goa'uld technology and haven't touched Earth technology yet since they don't like it if you copy their weapons - even if you improve them; I was told that I need permission to do that, and I didn't have time to get that

since they don't have a central authority to do that even though a global system should be obvious, but, apparently, you need to ask every single inventor for permission even though they have a patent office that should be handling that - did you know it's used to keep people from using others' inventions, not the other way around? That seems backwards, doesn't it?"

Entrapta was looking… well, like someone who had been running on caffeine and pure sugar for days. Which, a glance at the tray full of tiny pastries and a large teapot with a tiny cup told Sam, was exactly what Entrapta had been doing. Probably ever since they had returned from Saqqara. "There's a reason for that," she said, almost automatically. "But it's complicated."

"You always say that when something doesn't make sense on Earth," Entrapta replied. "But there's so much that doesn't make sense on your world. Anyway, I also worked on an alternative form of communication in case we can't bring the miniaturised system I showed you. So this…"

Sam felt guilt well up in her. She had been busy with debriefings and reports, and Daniel and Sha're needed help as well, but that was no excuse for neglecting another friend in need of help. And Entrapta clearly needed help dealing with this. But then, Sam wasn't her only friend. Where were the others?

"...and if we can't use the bones as speakers, I am looking into implants that directly connect to your nervous system, but that's a very challenging project. Although I think Alpha should be able to help us with it."

"Where's Hordak?" Sam asked.

"It was his turn to help Loki. But his implants won't help with this - they're not connected to his nervous system. Well, they are, but they aren't wired to be consciously controlled. Although I guess we could just hook up comm implants to our ears - or their nerves - and just have them transmit everything they hear. On the other hand, that would cause a feedback loop. Maybe a central control

unit would be needed to filter out loops? A dedicated stealth bot could handle that, I think. But if it loses connection to the network, that would stop, and we'd be back at square one, so to speak."

Sam winced. "I don't think everyone will want such an implant in their body." She couldn't think of anyone off-hand who would want an implant, much less this hypothetical one. Well, not amongst those who would be going on undercover and infiltration missions.

"Really? But it would be so useful if we can't carry our normal or the new modular gear!"

"I think it would need a lot of testing - especially the long-term effects - before it can be used in the field," Sam replied. "So we know it won't damage the user."

"Oh, that's probably right. Adora could probably heal that, but if we're on planets without magic, that won't work."

"We can't plan on Adora healing everyone," Sam pointed out. "She's needed for a lot of other tasks."

"Right. That's why we developed the synthetic symbionts. Anyway, what do you think about this? I just built it before you arrived!" Her hair tendrils held up what looked like a quarter of a spy bot. "It's supposed to fit with others and form a whole!"

Sam sighed and forced herself to smile. "Entrapta, when was the last time you slept?"

"What does that have to do with research?" Entrapta cocked her head to the side.

Sam wasn't fooled. "Did you sleep since we returned?"

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded, though her smile was a bit too wide.

"How long?" Sam asked.

“Did I show you another idea I had?”

That was answer enough. Sam sighed. “Entrapta! You can’t… This is not healthy. You need your rest.”

“We’re at war. I can rest once I’m done with my current project.” Entrapta shook her head and avoided Sam’s eyes.

For a moment, Sam was tempted to agree. She knew how annoying it was to cut your lab time short when you were about to solve a problem or finish a project. And she would be a hypocrite if she claimed to have never pulled an all-nighter. But she glanced at the various prototypes Entrapta had laid out, the notes on the screen… “And how long will that take?”

“Uh… that’s hard to say. Some of the design challenges are quite, well, challenging,” Entrapta replied.

“And you don’t think the challenge would be easier if you were well-rested?” Sam asked.

Entrapta looked a little guilty at that. “But the sooner I am done, the sooner I can rest.”

“And the more tired you are, the more mistakes you make.” Sam took a step forward and put her hand on her friend’s shoulder. “You’re not helping anyone if you work until you collapse.”

“But what if we have another mission, and we need this, and it’s not ready? We would lose another friend! Maybe more!” Entrapta blinked, then rubbed her eyes for a moment.

Ah. Sam suppressed a wince. “That’s not how it works,” she said. “We can’t know that.”

“If we had better gear with us, better weapons, we could have been faster, and our Tel’tak wouldn’t have been in position when the building’s top fell on it. Bra’tac would still be alive!” Entrapta shook her head. “That’s a fact!”

“That’s an assumption,” Sam corrected her. “The Ha’tak might have shot the Tel’tak down instead.”

“That’s very unlikely. They didn’t shoot the Tel’tak down, and they would have had even less time to do so if we just had been faster. We weren’t prepared enough!” Entrapta’s eyes were wet again, Sam noticed.

“But if we had different gear, we might not have ended up in the same situation,” Sam pointed out. “We might have chosen a different plan. We can’t second-guess our decisions like that.”

“But that’s what we did in the debriefing.”

Sam felt a sudden, unprofessional urge to hurt Admiral Kearsy. If he hadn’t run such a hostile debriefing, Entrapta might not feel so guilty. Might - Bra’tac’s death would have still affected her. And now I am second-guessing our actions, she thought. “Yes, we did. But we still can’t be sure how things would have gone if we had had different tools and weapons. Though it helps improving our procedures and equipment,” she added.

“And that’s what I am doing!”

Sam sighed. “Yes, and there’s nothing wrong with that. Except that you’re hurting yourself by not resting. It’s not…” She blinked. Oh, maybe she should have rested a bit more if she forgot how to reach Entrapta. “All the data we have shows that the less people rest, the worse they work.”

“You have data about that?” Entrapta looked surprised.

Sam nodded. “Yes. We’ve run experiments.”

“Can I see that data?”

“I don’t have it on me. I’d need to travel back to Earth to get it.” Sam hadn’t thought she’d need that kind of data.

“Ah.” Entrapta glanced at the rest of her lab.

“I can assure you, the data is conclusive,” Sam told her.

“If you say so…” Entrapta’s hair started fidgeting with her prototypes. “I did notice that I had a *slightly* higher-than-average failure rate with my experiments. Although the data I gathered did help with improving the prototypes. And Hordak said that was normal.”

“Before he took his turn in Research Station Alpha?”

“Yes.”

“Does he know you haven’t slept since then?” Sam raised her eyebrows.

“Ah…” Entrapta looked guilty.

And Sam felt guilty. But this was for Entrapta’s own good. “Come on, take some rest. We can look over the prototypes tomorrow.”

“We can do that now,” Entrapta grinned a bit weakly. “By my calculations, I have too much caffeine in my bloodstream to fall asleep for another hour and a half.”

Oh for… She had calculated this? A part of Sam wanted to throttle her friend. And another wanted that data. Just in case.

But she shook her head. “I think we shouldn’t work right now. Let’s talk about something else.”

“Alright,” Entrpata said. “What do you want to talk about?”

That was a good question, Sam had to admit. An embarrassingly good question. Most of what both of them liked was a bit too close to their work - or was their work. She couldn’t ask about the weather - she would never live that down should the General hear about it. Which he might; Entrapta had a tendency to reveal such things at the oddest moments. Well, they could discuss how to handle the loss of a friend, but that was a sensitive topic, not something to talk about when Entrapta was hopped on caffeine.

And it was a topic Sam would rather leave to a professional, but she didn't want to ask if Entrapta was planning to see a therapist. The Etherians had been looking into that, Sam knew, but she hadn't heard back from them since she had passed on the request for a list of trusted experts. Another topic for the future.

So Sam picked up one of the tiny muffins on Entrapta's desk and asked: "This looks good. Did you teach your staff some Earth recipes?"

Her friend perked up. "Oh, I got them all the data on Earth pastries I could find! Look at this!"

Yes, Sam thought as Entrapta showed her a list of recipes, that was a safe topic.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, November 15th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and she's now sleeping."

Catra nodded and ignored the slight glare from Sam. She did feel slightly guilty - she should have checked on Entrapta sooner; she had noticed that Entrapta was acting a little off, after all. And she would do better in the future. But she wasn't the only one at fault here - everyone else also had failed to notice that their friend needed help. And she was sure that they would have realised something was wrong once Entrapta had presented her latest designs to them.

Adora, though, looked like she thought she had personally hurt Entrapta. "That's… Thank you, Sam. I should have checked up on her much sooner! I can't believe I missed that."

"*We* missed it," Glimmer said before Catra could say it.

"Yes." Bow, too, looked abashed. "It's just… I didn't think she'd do this."

“She’s been doing such things before,” Adora said. “Remember when we met her?”

“That was different,” Glimmer protested. “She was having fun then, not feeling guilty.”

Ah, right. Catra had heard about that. Mainly from Entrapta, who had a sometimes unique view of things, but she had pieced together the rest later.

“Was that the first time she lost someone?” Sam asked.

Maybe the first time she lost someone she actually knew and cared about, Catra thought. She didn’t say so, though - that would have been unfair. “She was a bit isolated from the fighting, so to speak,” she said instead.

The others nodded.

“Ah.” Sam looked like she got it.

“And we might have focused a bit too much on the lack of special equipment for the mission in the debriefings,” Bow added.

“That was Admiral Asshole,” Glimmer objected.

“We also used it as an excuse,” Adora said in a serious tone. “And Entrapta would have felt responsible. Technology is her field. But she needs to understand that not everything is her fault.”

Catra raised her eyebrows at her - her lover thought everything was her fault.

Adora blushed a little in response but then set her jaw in that stubborn expression Catra knew so well.

“Even if it’s her responsibility, it’s not always her fault,” Glimmer said. “As a ruling princess, she should know that, but…” She shrugged.

“She’s not like other ruling princesses,” Bow said.

“Yes. And it is generally better to take responsibility as a ruler than to try to dodge it,” Glimmer added.

“But she shouldn’t overdo it.” Adora nodded again.

Catra cleared her throat, and her lover flushed some more.

“I wonder why Hordak didn’t notice anything,” Sam said.

Oh. Catra managed not to sigh. She didn’t like Hordak that much, but he had a decent excuse. “He probably thinks that’s normal,” she said. “He would do the same. Back in the Horde, he was often stuck in his lab while I ran things. And he probably did work himself to exhaustion for Horde Prime before that. He’s not really a people person.” Though power could make up for that to some degree.

“He did build up the Horde and took over the Scorpion Kingdom,” Glimmer objected.

Catra shrugged. “Yeah, but that probably was luck.” Or ineptitude on the part of Scorpia’s parents.

Sam looked like she didn’t agree, but that wasn’t Catra’s problem.

“We’ll have to talk to him as well. So this doesn’t repeat itself,” Adora said. “There will be more missions, and we’ll lose more people.”

That was war. Catra knew that. A voice in the back of her head whispered that as long as they didn’t lose people Entrapta connected to, things would be OK, and she felt angry at herself for thinking like that. Even though it was true. If you weren’t prepared to lose soldiers, you couldn’t wage war. And if you couldn’t handle losing soldiers, you couldn’t lead an army, either.

Something Adora knew - she and Catra had attended the same lessons back in cadet training - but sometimes seemed

determined to forget. “So, you’re going to talk to Hordak as well?” Catra asked Sam.

“Yes. I should check up on the research base anyway,” Sam replied.

“Yes,” Glimmer agreed. “It never hurts to double-check.”

Catra nodded. Hordak was a scientist, unlike the princesses usually supervising Loki and Morrison, so he would be harder to fool should Loki try to slip something under the radar, but he was also more likely to go along with questionable things. Like Alpha.

She blinked. On second thought… “Maybe we should also go and check up on things,” she said. “Alpha will listen to Adora above everyone else.”

“Right.” Glimmer firmly nodded. She was probably still a bit annoyed that while she laid claim to the entire moon, Alpha wasn’t beholden to her.

Well, that wasn’t Catra’s problem either. “Let’s go then.”

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HMNB Devonport, Devon, Britain, November 15th, 1999

Jack O’Neill was a little bit torn when he looked at the first Fleet Transport built on Earth, HMS Albion. Should he be glad about the Navy pukes getting shown up, proving that the Air Force should have been in control of the space forces, or annoyed that the Limeys had managed to beat American shipyards by several weeks?

“She’s a beauty, isn’t she?” Captain Baker, standing next to him on the pier, was beaming as he looked at the spaceship currently sitting in what used to be a drydock, according to what Jack knew about the Royal Naval base.

A beauty? The ship looked like someone had taken a Horde frigate, stuffed it into a container and then blew it up until it filled out most of the container, ending up with something that looked more like a brick with the edges smoothed out than a Horde frigate. Horde Prime had supposedly been fond of elegant designs, so Jack didn't know how that had slipped through. But saying that would needlessly annoy Baker, who seemed to be a decent fellow when he wasn't gushing about his new command. Jack found it a bit annoying, but he could understand the enthusiasm. "It has a certain charm," he said diplomatically.

"Oh, yes!" Baker nodded. "As fast as a frigate, but able to carry an entire brigade ready for combat! And she carries the shuttles to deploy the troops and enough firepower to provide ground support - or see an Al'kesh or two off!"

"No fighters, though." Jack couldn't resist.

"Well, no - but she's a transport and landing ship, not a carrier." Baker grinned. "We've got other ships for fighting an enemy fleet. I think the US Marines were looking into variants that could carry fighters, though last I heard, that didn't prove viable."

Yeah, Jack had heard about that. Mostly from Carter venting about having to look over the design notes. Apparently, the crayon-eaters wanted baby carriers, not just landing ships. Probably didn't trust the Navy to keep them safe. Well, Jack had mixed feelings about that himself. "They're still working on the modular transport concept," he said. "And probably will be working on that for years."

"I can see the appeal, but modifying an existing ship - and an alien design to boot - to that degree seems a bit tricky. It might be better to design that from scratch," Baker commented diplomatically.

"I think the idea was to create 'Space Jeep Carriers'," Jack explained.

“I see.” Baker was Royal Navy - he would be familiar with the CVEs from World War 2. Built to civilian specs and about as tough as that would suggest. “So, let me show the inside. Then we can discuss the best way to load and unload your troops.”

“Yeah.” That was what Jack was here, in Merry Old England - to help write the manual for embarking and disembarking troops from the new transports. He still thought it was a mistake - he had written the manual for embarking and disembarking troops from shuttles, but that was because they were basically transport aircraft that went into space, and he had experience with those. But troops didn’t live for weeks on a Hercules or Super Galaxy. On the other hand, Jack’s troops were the ones who would likely use these transports first, and if the Navy took over and treated this like a simple transport… He winced at the thought. Better do this right, he thought as he followed Baker to the gangway leading into the ship.

Inside, the ship looked as sleek and clean as Jack expected from a Horde ship - though instead of white, the Limeys had used grey paint. Jack liked the change. It felt more like a warship should look. The white made him think of a luxury yacht, too clean for a soldier.

“We’ve kept the bot storage areas,” Baker said as they walked through the crew quarters. “If we don’t get bots to transport, we can store additional supplies there.”

Was he fishing for information? Jack shrugged. “I think the bots are going to Etherian and mixed units. And to us,” he added with a grin.

“Oh? I heard they make good fire support units.”

“Yes, they do, but we don’t have the doctrine yet to use them effectively,” Jack explained. The first time they had trained with bots had been a disaster. They had been lucky Entrapta had programmed the bots so well, or they might have seriously hurt one of the soldiers getting in their way. And his troops were the

cream of the crop of the Alliance - he didn't want to imagine how the conscripts from France or Germany, or the National Guard units back home, would have done.

"Ah. Well, we'll figure it out. Just as we're figuring out space combat." Baker beamed again. "I can't wait to take her into action."

Once again, Jack managed to make a diplomatic comment. Barely.

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Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, November 15th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Well, the base is still standing," Catra commented as they stepped out of the shuttle that had brought them to the moon. "At least the hangar."

Adora frowned at her, as did Glimmer, but Catra shrugged in her usual way. And Adora couldn't really say that she would disagree. Hordak was not exactly the most trustworthy supervisor. She didn't think he would betray them, but he was too much of a 'mad scientist', as they said on Earth, for Adora to trust his judgement implicitly. Of course, he had more common sense than Entrapta, but that wasn't a high bar to clear - and he hadn't even noticed that something was wrong with her!

Which, she thought as they entered the base proper through the airlock connecting it to the hangar, we'll have to point that out to him quite clearly.

Alpha's projection appeared in front of them. "Adora. Welcome to Research Base Alpha! Do you wish a status report?"

"Yes, please," Adora replied without slowing down.

The projection fell in, floating next to them as they kept walking. "We have made further progress on the Asgard project. The lack

of test subjects is still slowing down progress, though that cannot be helped without altering the base orders."

Catra rolled her eyes next to her. Adora knew what her lover meant - she thought this was a blatant attempt to get Adora to relax her orders to the bot. It was a touchy issue. Adora didn't like commanding bots like Alpha or Light Hope like that. But Alpha was as driven as Light Hope when it came to pursuing their goals - maybe worse. Light Hope had tried to do the right thing despite her programming. Alpha… well, the bot had been constructed to facilitate and assist in biological research, according to Entrapta and Sam, but she seemed a bit too eager to work around Adora's orders.

So Adora nodded and said: "I'm sure you'll cope."

"Yes. In fact, the alternatives to live testing we were forced to develop are projected to improve overall efficiency once we have more robust models for our simulations. Though I must point out again that it would violate safety standards to skip the final live testing," Alpha went on.

"In my experience, the Ancients - the First Ones - often skipped that part," Sam commented.

"I am bound to obey my superiors," Alpha replied. "Even when they ignore standard safety procedures."

Adora winced at the implications of that. Maybe…

Catra frowned again. "Well, some of those safety procedures sound rather unsafe for the 'test subjects'", she said. "How many 'prototypes' died during the final testing of the genetic experiments here?"

"That's restricted information," Alpha retorted.

"Please answer," Adora said firmly.

"None." Alpha sounded a bit too bland.

Adora blinked. What? That didn't sound right.

Sam spoke up: "And how many died during the 'final live testing' that revealed the need for more tests?"

"Twenty-seven developed unexpected fatal flaws after maturing."

Sam hesitated for a moment, Adora noticed. But her friend pressed her lips together, then asked: "And what happened to those who developed unexpected non-fatal flaws?"

"Depending on the severity of the flaws, they were released or recycled."

"You don't recycle *people*!" Adora spat. "And sapients of all species are people!" she added after a moment. That was wrong! Completely, utterly wrong!

"Noted."

"Wait! Does that mean you didn't have that noted down yet?" Adora asked. Hadn't Alpha understood her orders?

"Not explicitly as a general order," Alpha replied. "Only as a specific order covering the current research project."

Adora clenched her teeth. Alpha was a bot constructed by the First Ones, she reminded herself. She couldn't be fully trusted. Even if it might not be her fault but the fault of the First Ones who had created her - who were the same people who were willing to destroy Etheria to defeat Horde Prime. In any case, whether she was consciously or unconsciously doing it, it was clear that she would try to find loopholes in Adora's orders wherever she could. "I think we need to go over the supervisor shifts again," she muttered.

"Definitely," Glimmer agreed. "It's worse than I thought."

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They couldn't trust Alpha. The AI was utterly amoral - and more cunning than Samantha Carter would have expected. She couldn't think of the bot as a sophisticated computer - it was a true sapient being, she reminded herself. Able to think for herself - and to think about ways to get around orders. She could probably think of malicious compliance as well. But there were ways to deal with that - Sam had worked with people who had their own agenda before.

They arrived at the actual research lab - and found Loki, Morrison and Hordak standing around a projection that looked like a blend of ancient Asgard and human.

"Ah, you've arrived. Good," Loki turned to nod at them. "You might be able to help us here - would this be considered attractive for you?" He pointed at the projection.

Sam wasn't the only one to blink. What kind of question was that?

Catra was blunter: "What?"

"We are considering restoring sexual reproduction to the Asgard as a possible way to ensure their genome won't enter another degradation process," Alpha explained. "Though while the biological and genetic aspects are clear, we haven't been able to extrapolate the sociological changes."

Sam looked at Morrison. Hordak was a clone, and Loki was… well, also a clone, but Morrison was a human. He should know about sex. According to what she had heard, he had a certain reputation in his circles.

The scientist blushed a little. "Well, we're dealing with an alien species that has abandoned sexual reproduction for millennia. We cannot expect them to mimic humans."

"Although if we want that to be possible, the new appearance should be both compatible and attractive to humans," Loki added. "Which is why we need your data."

Oh, God! Sam closed her eyes for a moment and muttered: "I really hope this is their idea of a joke. The General will never stop joking about 'Asgard needs women' once he hears this."

Catra giggled, so she must have caught Sam's words.

Adora, though, shook her head. "Wait! You can't just decide that your species will sexually reproduce from now on!"

Loki frowned - at least it looked that way. "If that is the best way to keep our genome stable - and preliminary data seems to indicate that, especially since it worked for the Ancients - then that is the course of action needed to save my species."

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again.

Catra shook her head. "What if they don't want to be saved if that's the price?"

"No one will be forced to have their genes altered," Loki said. "And they could still opt for asexual reproduction if they wanted - which they should since it's the objectively superior option as long as you mix genes from multiple donors - but straight cloning will have to be prohibited to avoid a repeat of our current problem."

"Yes." Hordak nodded. "While the act of initiating sexual reproduction is quite pleasurable, the actual reproduction using a human body as an incubator is inefficient, debilitating and dangerous to the host, and, therefore, not recommended. Which should be obvious to anyone looking into the matter."

That was… Well, Sam couldn't say she disagreed with the idea.

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Catra snorted. As if anyone sane would want to carry a baby to term inside them unless they had no access to magic or medicinal technology! She remembered those lessons from their time as Horde cadets very well. Of course, Hordak would follow the same

advice. He might have sex with Entrapta, but any babies would be grown in a pod.

“Right.” Adora nodded.

“But just adding the option for sexual reproduction will alter your species on a fundamental level,” Sam pointed out.

“We’re altering our very genes - that’s a much more fundamental change,” Loki retorted.

“Of the individual. But changing your entire society goes further than that,” Sam said.

“Which would also be the result of altering genes.” Loki tried to be clever.

“You don’t have to add sexual reproduction as long as you don’t do straight cloning, which you already said will be prohibited.” Sam shook her head. “I’m not a geneticist, but I have reviewed your reports.”

“Yes, we don’t have to - but more options are better,” Morrison said.

“And sexual reproduction is the norm in the known sapient species, therefore indicating a significant evolutionary advantage over asexual reproduction,” Loki added.

Ah. “And here I thought you were just curious about sex,” Catra said. “Which, by the way, is something great you’re missing out on right now.” She stretched and grinned when she saw Adora blush and Glimmer roll her eyes.

“The Asgard have abandoned such things long ago, but we have kept records,” Loki replied.

Records they apparently kept better than their data about their own genome. If Jack were here, he’d make a joke about deleting

vital information to save porn. Since he wasn't… "I see you've got your priorities settled," Catra said.

Adora looked confused, Glimmer rolled her eyes again, and Loki… nodded in apparent agreement. "Indeed. Since we're already changing our genome, it makes sense to add more improvements - or options - while we're at it."

Catra wasn't so sure about that. In her experience, adding more objectives and complexity to a plan generally lowered its chances of success. But whether or not the Asgard had sex again was neither her problem nor her decision.

"That doesn't explain why you would ask about human aesthetics," Sam said, still frowning.

"According to our data, humans are one of the species most open to sexual relationships with other species and, therefore, a good role model - as long as the aesthetics are compatible," Loki said.

Sam looked surprised for a moment, then glared at Morrison. "What kind of porn did you show him?"

"I didn't!" Morrison protested.

"I accessed your cultural data," Loki said. "Both ancient and recent."

Catra nodded. "That would do it." Sam glared at her, but she ignored it. Daniel had told them about ancient Earth legends and myths often enough on the way to Earth. Of course, Loki would come to that conclusion! Wait… hadn't he been part of some of *those* myths?

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 16th, 1999

"...so, Entrapta is on forced leave?" Jack O'Neill asked his former second-in-command. He didn't think anyone had the formal authority to order her to rest. Well, maybe Adora had, as the Supreme Commander.

"Not officially," Carter replied. "But effectively, yes. Adora and the others will ensure she has completely recovered before she returns to work."

"Ah." He nodded before grinning. "And she built a lot of nifty gadgets for us."

Carter frowned at him. "That's what drove her into exhaustion."

"Well, scientists do that from time to time. Working too much." He shrugged as casually as he could.

Carter blushed at that. Too bad Daniel wasn't here - Jack's friend had pulled overnighters more than once as well, and not always for critical translations. But he was with Sha're in a retreat, helping her recover from her ordeal. They would probably move to Etheria for a while soon, last Jack had heard, before they'd brave an Earth city. And speaking of Etheria… "And our mad scientists haven't been developing bioweapons or plotting to take over the world?"

"Not to our best knowledge, sir." Carter nodded. "Although if they wanted to, Alpha would probably help them."

"Aren't AIs supposed to take over the world themselves?" Jack joked, even though the thought of an Ancient AI supporting such plots was very concerning. The things they could create on that moon…

"That is a movie cliché, sir." Carter didn't show any reaction to his comment and remained the professional officer he knew and lo… *liked* to work with. She was the best second-in-command any officer could wish for. Even now that she - technically, he reminded himself - wasn't his subordinate any more. Which had effects on regulations that he didn't want to think about.

“More seriously, is it safe?”

“To the best of our knowledge, yes, sir.” Carter nodded again. But she seemed to hesitate, Jack noticed.

He raised his eyebrows.

She pressed her lips together. “The changes to the Asgard genome they are planning are quite extensive, sir. More extensive than expected.”

That sounded… also concerning. “Aren’t they trying to build a better body and genome from the ground up? I’ve seen the pictures,” he said. And he had read the reports. The Asgard had changed *a lot* since they started cloning themselves. And Loki was planning even greater changes?

“Yes, sir. But they’re also planning to add the ability to reproduce sexually.”

He slightly tilted his head, prompting her to explain.

“That would cause a drastic change in their society. They’ve been living without sexual reproduction for tens of thousands of years. To add this back in would upset their entire society on a fundamental level.”

“Yeah, I guess everyone going through puberty at once wouldn’t be great for society,” Jack commented.

Instead of pretending she didn’t find his comment funny while she twisted her lips into a hint of a smile, Carter nodded as if he had been serious. “That is an apt comparison, sir. They would be like teenagers - only without any adult help or even up-to-date information about how to deal with this. It would be mitigated to a degree, I think, by the fact that this would be a conscious choice, so not everyone would be affected at once, but that would also cause the risk of dividing their society.”

“And sooner or later, most of them will want to find out what the big deal is about sex,” Jack said.

She nodded again. “That is a plausible outcome, yes.”

“It’s too bad Daniel isn’t here. That would be right up his alley.”

“Yes. He’d love it.”

But Daniel was busy being reunited with his wife. And so someone else would have to deal with this. “Well, I’d say that sounds like a future Asgard problem, but since they’re busy with their war against the Replicators, anything that shakes their society might also affect us.”

Teenagers in command of space battleships was a frightening thought, though Jack hoped that the Asgard would have the sense not to let their generals and captains do this until the war was won. Though they had only met two Asgard, and one of them was a mad scientist and the other a high-ranking officer, so it wasn’t as if Jack - or anyone else - knew enough about the Asgard to tell. They certainly couldn’t trust Loki’s information.

“Yes, sir.”

“Do you have an estimate for how long our dear alien mad scientist will take to finish his project?”

“No, sir. I would have to guess blindly. Any new and unforeseen problem could delay the project for an unknown length of time. It’s ground-breaking research, after all.”

He narrowed his eyes a little. Carter wasn’t considering joining that project, was she? He needed her on Earth. For the Alliance.

“Well, it’s a potential problem, then.” That meant he could focus on how to deploy his troops from the Fleet Transports. And maybe ask for one of them to be permanently assigned to his command. “But I think the Asgard can sort this out themselves. They’re old

enough. I don't really think they will need or want sex advice from us." He chuckled at his own joke.

Carter still didn't laugh. She cleared her throat. "That might not be entirely accurate, sir."

"Did you just quote Independence Day?"

She blushed. "Loki seems, ah, interested in the human approach to sexuality. He may consider humans as potential sexual partners for the new Asgard. He was asking for aesthetical advice so the new bodies would be attractive for humans."

Jack blinked. That was… "That's supposed to be a Hollywood cliché! A cheap, silly B-movie cliché! Asgard needs humans?" He shook his head. Oh my God, first Anise wanted a baby from him, and now this? What was it with mad alien scientists and babies? he asked himself.

Carter nodded with a grimace. "Yes, sir. No one seems to have told Loki that. On the other hand, if we consider the Norse myths about Loki…"

Jack grimaced as well. Daniel had gone into details in that briefing that Jack really could've done without. And speaking of Daniel… "Alright, I don't want to disturb Daniel, but… as soon as he is back with us, we'll get him working on this!"

"Yes, sir. That should…" A beep from her laptop interrupted her. A familiar beep.

"Message from Etheria?" Jack asked.

"Yes." Carter slowly nodded, eyes on the screen. "It seems the spy bot network picked up a request from Thor to meet with us."

"What a coincidence," Jack said in the flattest tone he could manage.

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The Asgard Question Part 1

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 17th, 1999

"...and the United Nations Human Rights Task Force has been criticised again for focusing on countries that are not members of the Alliance. James Malone is currently at the United Nations Headquarters in New York, where a protest is being held. James?"

"I hear you, Carol. Yes, we're here in front of the United Nations Headquarters, and behind me, you can see the people protesting what they call favouritism. They demand that the American prison system be abolished as inhumane. But as you can see, they have been joined by various others protesting the Etherian presence on American or Earth soil."

Adora frowned as she watched the TV in the meeting room. There were a lot of people on the screen holding up signs and banners. Well, compared to some of the protests she had seen on Earth, it was relatively tiny, but they were very vocal. But… "What does religion have to do with prisons?" she asked. Many of the signs didn't even say anything about human rights or prisons.

"Nothing. But the nutcases who want us gone because we're abominations in the face of their god or something will jump at every opportunity to recruit more idiots," Catra commented without glancing up from her tablet.

Adora shook her head. She still didn't understand those people. Adora and her friends hadn't done anything to those people. Yet a few lines in some ancient book were enough to cause such hatred?

"We contacted Amnesty International. They stated that they were in contact with the task force and were preparing several lawsuits about the treatment of prisoners in the United States. What do you think about that, James?"

"Well, Carol, that will take a while to reach the Supreme Court, and those people here want action now. Though I don't think they all agree on what kind of action they want - some are chanting 'aliens out', as you can hear, and others demand that the Etherians raid every prison in the USA. But it seems that the NYPD has the situation under control - as you can see, they have enough officers on the scene to intervene should anything happen."

"Thank you, James. Now, back to related news. Speaking of lawsuits, the Etherians have launched a few lawsuits of their own, demanding that 'The Church of She-Ra' be recognised as a religion. We have an expert here in the studio, Dr Kevin Stuart, who covers this matter in his lectures at Yale. Kevin, what do you say about this?"

"Well, Carol, first, I have to correct you or whoever wrote this line. The lawsuits launched do not aim for official recognition; they are aimed at rules and circumstances at various schools that members of the Church of She-Ra claim are discriminatory against their faith."

Adora blinked. "We did what? Who did that?" Oh. "Priest!"

Catra snickered, And Adora glared at her. "It's not funny! It's… I have to tell him that he can't sue someone in my name!"

"Technically, he's not. He's doing it in the name of your church." Catra touched a few keys on her tablet. "Oh, and I don't think you want to stop those lawsuits anyway. Look!" She held her tablet up, and Adora looked at the texts on it.

And blinked again. "What school prohibits *public displays of affection*? Do they hate love or something?"

Catra shrugged. "Probably; you've heard what their priests consider mortal sins."

Adora had. Far more than she wanted, to be honest. She quickly read on. "What dress code is that? Immodest? Bow is one of the

most modest people I know, and he'd violate this dress code!"

"Yeah," Catra agreed. "Apparently, he wouldn't be allowed in most schools in the USA."

Adora clenched her teeth. "Alright. I'll let Priest do this." It was for a good cause - to think people treated their children like this! In school! They were insane!

"It's not as if you could stop him, anyway," Catra said with a grin.

Adora frowned at her lover. "It's not funny. I am no goddess."

"Depends on the definition," Catra retorted. "You'd fit the description of a lot of what the humans considered deities back in the day."

"Back when they worshipped the Goa'uld?" Adora scoffed.

"Well, we don't know if they took over existing pantheons or invented them. Seth and Osiris claim the latter, but…" Catra shrugged.

"Yes." Adora nodded. They couldn't be trusted.

"But I certainly think you deserve to be worshipped," Catra went on, grinning.

Adora blushed against her will. That wasn't the point!

"And I think a little display of affection would be the right kind of worship." Catra slid out of her seat and stepped in front of Adora. "Don't you agree?"

"Ah…" Adora trailed off when her lover slipped onto her lap. And before she could remember what she had been about to say, Catra had started kissing her, and that completely derailed her thoughts.

"Alright, sorry for being late, but… Oh!"

Adora gasped and broke the kiss. Jack was standing in the door, grinning at them.

And Catra, who must have heard him approach, giggled as she stood. “Don’t worry. We kept ourselves busy.”

“No, we didn’t!” Adora protested.

“OK, I’ll admit - we didn’t do any work and just fooled around.”

“Wait, no! That’s not what I meant!” Adora glared at her, then at the chuckling Jack.

“OK, enough fooling around,” Jack said as he closed the door. “Let’s discuss Thor.”

“Unofficially,” Catra said. “Since officially, this is just a meeting about integrating princesses into your command.” She rolled her eyes. “And if anyone on the general staff believes we won’t discuss Thor, then they are unfit for their posts.”

“It’s all about plausible deniability,” Jack replied with a grin. “They know we’ll be talking about this - well, the ones who have the clearance for it - and they hate it, but as long as I don’t flaunt it, they’ll ignore it.”

Adora frowned. “It’s only natural that we’re discussing this. All of us know about the matter - we all have met Thor - and we’re friends.” Which was the most important part. She trusted Jack, Sam, Daniel and Teal’c - and, of course, the princesses in the Alliance - a lot more than she trusted the command council or the Alliance general staff. Not that she distrusted them, of course, but… they weren’t her friends.

“Exactly,” Jack said.

“Of course,” Catra added, “you’re also bypassing the chain of command and meddling in politics.”

Jack frowned at her, though with a slight pout, so she had a point, Adora knew. “It’s not meddling. It’s just hashing stuff out. Advising our Supreme Commander,” he said. “Who will discuss this with the rest, so everything’s alright. Technically.”

“It’s not as if they could do anything to you, anyway.” Catra snorted. “Not officially, at least.”

“And if they try screwing with my command to get to me, I’ll nail them to the wall,” Jack said.

“Sabotage won’t be tolerated,” Adora said with a nod. Especially over such a petty thing! “But we were going to talk about Thor,” she prompted him.

“Right. Thor. Supreme Commander of the Asgard Fleet. Who wants a meeting with you.”

“With us,” Adora corrected him.

“And it’s a meeting that couldn’t be done over comms,” Catra added. “So, it’s probably sensitive, important or both.”

“Daniel would say that could just be how the Asgard do things - they might want personal meetings to talk,” Jack said.

Loki should have mentioned that, Adora thought. On the other hand, they usually talked in person to him anyway. It was better to talk face to face - more personal. And… “I don’t think he’d call for a meeting if it weren’t important anyway, not while he’s fighting a war.”

“Yes, he had that ‘very responsible officer’ vibe,” Jack agreed. “Or what passes for it amongst the Asgard. We’ve got a lot of them in the Alliance as well.”

“Like you. You just try to hide it,” Catra told him, flashing her fangs. Jack snorted in return. “Anyway, do you have any idea what he might want?” She cocked her head sideways, and her ears twitched.

“The analysts don’t have much to go on with - well, the ones with the clearance to know about this,” Jack said. “He might want to tell us that the Asgard won their war and now want to attack the Goa’uld with us. Or he might want to ask for help with their war because it’s not going as well as he claimed when we met.”

Adora nodded. “Loki probably would have told us about his people losing a war, though he might not know it.”

“If he hasn’t some way to check on his people, I’ll escort Swift Wing on a tour of Earth’s elementary schools,” Catra commented. “But he might not tell us even if he knows.”

Adora hoped Loki would be more open with them, especially if it was so important. On the other hand, revealing such information might be seen as treason by the Asgard. Or he might honestly not know about it because it was a secret kept by the rulers of the Asgard.

“Or this is about Loki,” Jack said.

Adora winced. That was the worst case they had come up with as well.

“You mean, Thor found out we’re harbouring a wanted criminal and wants us to hand him over,” Catra said.

“Which we won’t do.” Adora shook her head. They had promised to help him save the Asgard, and they would keep that promise.

“We don’t exactly know everything that Loki did while trying to find a cure for the Asgard,” Jack said, looking at her with a guarded expression.

Adora frowned. “Even if he did bad things, if he wants to change and make up for it, we’ll help him.” He was trying to save his species.

Catra pressed her lips together and wasn’t looking at either Adora or Jack.

Adora suppressed a sigh. She had expected that.

“Well, there are some lines you don’t cross,” Jack said. His expression hadn’t changed. “If he has done stuff that is inexcusable…”

Adora didn’t flinch and met his eyes. “If he wants to change and do better, we’ll help him.” Everyone deserved a second chance.

“Earth isn’t as forgiving when it comes to certain crimes,” Jack said. “And if we have to fight the Asgard over Loki, the Alliance might not be happy.”

“Loki is on Etheria, though,” Adora pointed out. “In Bright Moon’s domain.”

Catra muttered something about ‘Paperclip’. Adora didn’t know what she meant, but Jack seemed to get it - he grimaced a little. She’d have to ask her lover after this.

“Well, there are precedents,” Jack said. “But would you really want to go to war with the Asgard to protect Loki? In the worst case, I mean.”

“I don’t think they’ll fight a war over him,” Adora said. “Not when he’s working so hard to save them.”

At least, she hoped so.

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Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, November 17th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“Thor has asked for a meeting with you?”

Loki did sound surprised, Samantha Carter thought. But she didn’t know him well enough to be certain - he might be acting. She nodded. “Yes, a meeting with the Alliance,” she confirmed. “He didn’t say what the meeting would be about.”

"Ah. He wouldn't - while we have since improved our communications, early in the war, the Replicators had limited success in defeating our encryption. While unnecessary, the fleet has stuck to strict information security protocols," Loki said. "I've long tried to make people understand that the tiny additional security such procedures provide is not worth the loss of timely sharing of crucial information they cause, which hinders both our military and scientific efforts."

That sounded arrogant to Sam; Information security was crucial to conducting any war with a peer-level opponent. Loose lips sank ships. And while research profited from shared information, so did spying. But this wasn't the time to argue about it. "Do you know what this might be about?"

"Unfortunately, my contact with the rest of my species has been somewhat limited lately," Loki said. "I am, as you would say, 'out of the loop' regarding the concerns of the Asgard High Council."

That implied - either correctly or not - that he once had been privy to that. Sam inclined her head. "But there isn't anything publicly known that might prompt such a meeting?"

"I have not paid attention to what the public believes," Loki replied with a slight hint of disdain. "They do not shape our species's policy."

Now, that was very plausible, in Sam's opinion. Loki wasn't the type to worry about the views of those he deemed his lessers. She doubted he would even pay lip service to caring about the Alliance's opinion If he didn't need their help. Still, it was also clear that he was evading the real question. "Could he have discovered that you're working with us on fixing the Asgard genome?" She watched him; she wasn't a diplomat, or Daniel, but she had been working for most of her career with scientists with a similar attitude to Loki's.

And he twitched a little. "That is very unlikely. I would say impossible, but that wouldn't be scientific. I have left no

information about our agreement anywhere Thor could have access to, much less access without me finding out about it."

He did seem sincere there, though Sam couldn't be sure. But she couldn't push him further, or it would feel like a straight interrogation. "I see."

"I assume you won't inform Thor of my current work and location."

Sam shook her head. "Based on our current knowledge, we do not plan to."

"That implies you might do so. That would be a going back on our deal."

Revealing their deal with Loki would go against the spirit, but probably not the letter of their agreement. But that wasn't Sam's decision. "While unlikely, there is the possibility that circumstances would force us to reveal this." Like Adora and her friends deciding that honesty was the best policy.

"What circumstances might necessitate such a course of action?"

Finding out that Loki had done worse in pursuit of his goal than what they already knew and assumed, in Sam's opinion. However, that might not be enough for the Etherians - they already knew that Loki was responsible for the creation of Horde Prime and so, albeit indirectly, for everything that Horde Prime and the Horde had done and still worked with him. "I cannot say," she said, half-lying. "But it's not impossible for new information to cause a policy change. Anything else wouldn't be scientific."

He frowned at that. Or at her using his own words against him. Sam didn't care. Loki was… He made Hordak look like a great friend in comparison. And knowing Hordak and his past, that was quite the feat. "I see," he said. "Where will you meet him?"

"Cimmeria," she said.

“Where you met Thor the first time.” He nodded. “An obvious choice.”

So obvious he had to ask to confirm it. Sam nodded anyway.

“And when will you meet with him?”

“Tomorrow,” she said. If Loki wanted to find out, he could just attempt to contact Entrapta - who should be fit for work again by then - and the other princesses under some pretext. If they were unavailable, odds were the meeting was taking place.

“It’s not a real emergency then, or he would have pressed for a quicker meeting,” Loki commented.

Sam filed the information away. Daniel would be interested in such comments. “Is there anything we should know before the meeting?” she asked.

Loki tilted his head slightly to the side. “Nothing comes to mind. But please keep me informed.”

“Of course.” Sam nodded once more.

“Good. When will Entrapta resume her work?”

“Probably tomorrow,” Sam said. But why was he asking after Entrapta? She wasn’t really that involved with their work here.

“Good. Hordak has been, as you would say, ‘off’ because of her, and his efficiency has suffered as a result, affecting our research.”

Sam withstood the urge to make a comment about not being jealous of Entrapta for being with Hordak. That was more the General’s style, not hers. And she also would rather not find out that her joke was actually correct. Not after she had heard Loki’s plans for the sexuality and appearance of the future Asgard.

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Gate Area, Cimmeria, November 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra realised Cimmeria's Stargate area had changed since their last visit. It was subtle, but she could tell. However, she couldn't tell if it went beyond repairing or replacing the defence system they had wrecked. But her friends could. She looked at Entrapta, who was jumping down from Emily's dome, her hair taking the brunt of the impact.

Her friend looked around, then at her multitool. "Oh… they added more defences. And more scanners."

That was good to know. If the Asgard had left the planet's security the same, that would have meant that they were either unable or unwilling to spare the resources to improve gate security. Or too arrogant to think they needed to.

"Hidden underground," Sam added. "But they aren't armoured or particularly well hidden."

"Tripwires, then," Jack said. "Could you disable them without noticing?"

"Hm…" Entrapta bit her lower lip. "Probably, I think. If they haven't changed the systems too much compared to last time, it should be easy. Otherwise, it would be a challenge!"

She was perking up, Catra noted. That was a good sign. To see Entrapta restrained and calm was just wrong. A bad sign - if you were superstitious.

"Good to know. But, ah, don't do anything. This was just a hypothetical question," Jack said. "We aren't here to sabotage the Asgard."

"Got it!" Entrapta nodded. "But you want us ready to do it if we need it."

"Well… yes." Jack nodded.

“Thor has acted honourably toward us when we met him,” Teal’c said.

“He almost got you killed,” Jack retorted.

“He thought I served the False Gods.” Teal’c didn’t shrug, but he tilted his head slightly as if that explained and excused everything. And, for him, it probably did.

Catra kind of understood the sentiment. If someone had made a trap for Horde members, and she walked into them… Well, she probably deserved it. For what she had done and for not noticing the trap.

“They shouldn’t have built a lethal trap in the first place,” Adora disagreed. “That’s irresponsible. What if they killed a Tok’ra?”

“Yes, their IFF procedure was rather sloppy,” Entrapta agreed. “Though that was probably based on bad data. If they had known about the Tok’ra, they wouldn’t have done that.”

“Or so we hope,” Jack voiced Catra’s own thoughts. “So… who’s going to announce our presence? Anyone seen a doorbell?”

“I don’t think we need a bell - the sensors will have registered the gate activation,” Entrapta replied. “I think we just have to wait. Though last time, Thor was able to communicate with us through the systems planted at the gate.”

“Correct. Greetings, Tau’ri and Etherians,” a voice sounded from one of the pillars surrounding the gate.

Catra was sure Thor had waited for this moment to announce his presence. Pretty dramatic - though that was probably better than Loki’s sneakiness.

“Ah, hello. Thor, Supreme Commander of the Asgard Fleet, I presume?” Jack asked.

“Correct again. I would invite you to my vessel. Do you accept?”

“Well, it would be pretty impolite to refuse your hospitality,” Jack replied.

And it wouldn’t actually be safer - Thor would be in his ship in orbit and able to bombard them from there if he meant them harm. Although, unless he had arrived in his ship right now, it meant neither Emily’s sensors nor the spy bot they had sent through the Stargate in advance had detected the Asgard ship. Granted, neither bot had the power of a proper ship behind their scanners, but they would have detected a Goa’uld craft in orbit.

“Stand by for transport, then.”

Catra clenched her teeth. The Asgard had the same teleporters that Horde Prime had had in his flagship. And the memories she had of the time she had used it…

She heard a humming noise and felt the air vibrate - though that might be her imagination. A moment later, they were inside Thor’s ship. Yes, she confirmed their location with a quick glance - it looked the same as it had during their first visit.

And Thor was waiting in the doorway to the next room. “Welcome aboard,” he said, bowing his head. “Please have a seat.” He gestured to the room, where several chairs were waiting - sized for an average human or Etherian, not an average Asgard, Catra saw. Quite considerate. Was Thor trying to butter them up, or was that standard Asgard procedure? She didn’t know. Too bad Daniel wasn’t with them. But if Catra had been reunited with Adora after her lover had been kidnapped for several years, well, she wouldn’t leave her side either.

“Thank you,” Glimmer replied.

“Yeah, thank you. We travelled a long way to Cimmeria,” Jack added.

Adora and Bow were the only ones who laughed at the stupid joke as they entered and sat down.

“So, you wanted to meet with us?” Adora said, leaning forward.

“Yes.” Thor nodded. “It’s a somewhat delicate matter. Embarrassing as well as potentially dangerous.”

Catra sat straighter. That sounded bad. Did he know about the deal with Loki?

“As you know, several Asgard were interacting with the humans on your planet in the guise of their gods,” Thor started to explain. “Myself and my father amongst them. And another Asgard, Loki. Who developed a colourful but by no means undeserved reputation for trickery and feats of what the humans at the time called magic.”

“Ah.” Jack nodded.

Catra tensed a little, then forced herself to relax. They had expected this.

“He is an accomplished scientist,” Thor went on, “but he doesn’t share the same ethics as most Asgard.”

“An ‘the ends justify the means’ type?” Jack acted as if he didn’t know it already.

“I think that would be a fitting description, yes.” Thor seemed to hesitate.

Catra glanced at Adora. Her lover bit her lower lip. She was probably trying to apologise already.

“And, unfortunately, we lost track of him a while ago. That wouldn’t concern you, but recent information we uncovered does.” Thor sighed. “Based on the data we recovered - research data from our last visits - it seems his interest in your planet and species was renewed, and he might attempt to acquire genetic samples for experiments.”

Catra blinked. Oh.

"Now, it is likely that he would target one of the many planets held in the grip of the Goa'uld Empire, where your species can be found. But he is unpredictable, and, based on some past predicaments with altered samples, he might wish to acquire a sample from your home planet."

Oh. This wasn't about the deal they had with Loki - Thor wanted to warn them of his fellow Asgard.

This was very awkward!

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In Orbit above Cimmeria, November 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Ah. And you think Loki might not politely ask for such a sample," Jack O'Neill said, nodding and keeping his features bland. He felt a bit bad about the act - Thor was trying to warn them about Loki, not knowing they had a deal with his brother.

But if Jack felt bad about it inside, Adora wasn't even hiding it - Jack saw her grimacing and glancing at the others, biting her lower lip.

"He is not fond of asking," Thor said. "I think it's because he was so often refused permission by the Asgard High Council for some of his experiments, he assumes no permission will be forthcoming anyway. Although, since you have at least technological parity with us and are an unknown power, he might attempt a more diplomatic approach first. But he also might choose to attempt an underhanded or even dangerous course of action."

Was that a subtle way to ask if they had met Loki? Jack couldn't tell. He hadn't exactly been spending a lot of time with Loki, so he couldn't really read the Asgard that well - he wasn't twitching with surprise, at least. He glanced at Carter, but she was focused on Thor and so was no help either. They really should have brought Daniel for that. Still, if they played this cool, they could probably…

Adora cleared her throat. “We were actually approached by Loki.”

…just blurt it out. Jack closed his eyes for a moment. He should have expected this.

“You were?” Thor seemed surprised - he jerked a little.

Entrapta nodded several times. “Oh, yes! He needed help with fixing your genetic degradation. We’re working on that with him - well, some of us are.”

“He asked for your help?” Thor blinked. Then he frowned - as far as Jack could tell. “And he informed you about the state of the Asgard’s genome?”

That was probably a state secret. Loki was in deep trouble now - though, in Jack’s opinion, the Asgard mad scientist probably had been in deep trouble already. They had caught him faking a Replicator outbreak, after all.

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded with a smile.

“I wouldn’t have expected him to be so open about our troubles,” Thor said.

“We were very persuasive,” Glimmer said with a toothy grin. “One of his past experiments affected us, and we wanted to know why he took such risks.”

Thor frowned. “Did you threaten him?”

With you, Jack thought. But mentioning that wouldn’t be very helpful.

“We confronted him with the results of his experiments,” Glimmer said.

Thor frowned again. “The Clones of Horde Prime?”

And that was why trying to be clever by telling the veiled truth wasn't a good idea when talking to aliens, Jack noted. Thor obviously had looked into the whole Horde Prime thing since their last meeting.

"Yes," Adora said.

"So, they were his creation…" Thor sighed and shook his head in a very human gesture. "Brother, you never change, do you?"

"Anyway," Adora went on, "since we have access to a First Ones - an Ancients - research station specialised in genetic engineering, we offered him our help for saving your species, and he accepted."

"And we're making good progress!" Entrapta added.

Thor turned his head slightly to the side to look at them. "You expect to solve our problem?"

"Yes." Entrapta nodded with a wide smile. "All the research data we have accumulated supports that."

"My brother has been optimistic about his research in the past, but it has never worked out," Thor said.

"Well, the data we have doesn't lie. And we already solved a more urgent problem with another species, so there's no reason why we shouldn't be able to solve this either!" Entrapta beamed at Thor. "We're not giving up; don't worry!"

"I do not worry about Loki giving up," Thor replied, frowning a little. At least that's what it looked like. "I worry about him not stopping even past the point it becomes obvious that his idea will not succeed - or will not be worth the cost."

Yeah, that sounded like a typical problem of Loki to Jack. Next to mission and feature creep.

“The whole research is conducted under supervision,” Carter said. “Close supervision.”

Thor inclined his head. “Loki has earned his reputation as a trickster.”

“We’re aware of that. And we know how dangerous he can be,” Glimmer told him.

Jack nodded, even though that sounded a bit too confident for someone who had just discovered how untrustworthy the research station’s AI was.

“I do not want to question your experiences, but I have known Loki for longer than you have,” Thor said. “Far longer than any of you were alive. I know him better than anyone else - and yet, as today’s revelations demonstrated, he keeps surprising me. And the High Council.”

“Well, you’re his brother,” Catra said. “You might not be entirely objective.”

Thor frowned at her. “And you might be overconfident due to your lack of experience with him.”

“Well, we’ve been working him for a while now,” Entrapta said. “And Alpha answers to Adora - and Jack - and she controls the station. So, it should be safe. Reasonably safe. Besides, we’re making progress, and Loki wouldn’t risk that, would he?”

Thor sighed again. “I am afraid that he would. He is neither the most patient nor the wisest amongst us. Far too often, he proves to be too clever for his own good.”

“Yeah, that sounds like the Loki from our myths,” Jack said. At least some of the stories.

“They are based on events that took place. At least some of them, I suppose. Even though they were distorted by our, ah, deception,” Thor said.

“You mean, by your decision to pose as gods,” Teal’c spoke up.

“Yes. In hindsight, it might not have been the best plan to avoid unduly influencing your development.” Thor nodded. “However, I would like to see the security measures myself - there is too much at stake to trust your claims blindly.”

“And you want to see your brother,” Adora said, nodding.

Thor inclined his head again, and Jack sighed. The Alliance brass better not blame him for this.

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Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, November 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“Brother.”

“Brother.”

Adora winced at the tone of the Asgard’s greetings. Thor and Loki were so tense… The way they were eyeing each other seemed worse than her worst encounters with Catra during the war.

Then Loki turned to glare at Sam. “You said you would not reveal my work or location.”

“I said new information might change that,” Sam replied. She did flush a little, though.

Adora pressed her lips together but didn’t flinch. Telling Thor had been her decision. And it was the right one. Honesty was the best policy. “Thor wanted to warn us that you had taken an interest in Earth.”

“And he was quite eloquent about the danger you could present - the lengths you’d go to achieve your goal,” Jack cut in.

She frowned at him. This wasn't the time for quips and clever remarks. "It wouldn't have been fair to leave him worrying over your plans. Especially since you don't pose a danger to us." Or so Adora hoped.

"Yes!" Entrapta smiled. "So, we took Thor with us so he can see for himself that everything's fine and that our research is progressing nicely!"

"I would not quite call my brother left free to conduct experiments in a research station of the Gate Builders 'fine'," Thor said.

"That is because you cannot understand my work," Loki retorted. "You never could. And you fear what you cannot understand."

"No, my fears are based on experience with your past deeds." Thor shook his head. "Have you told your 'friends' what you did? The experiments that led to you being known as the sire of monsters in the tales of the Norse?"

"We know he is responsible for the creation of Horde Prime," Glimmer said.

"What?" Thor whirled to stare at her, then back at Loki. "I thought you were working for him, maybe with him, to create his clones and used the opportunity to conduct experiments with Asgard DNA, but you created *him*?"

Loki rolled his eyes, or tried to. "Did you really think he would have let me introduce my own DNA to his clones? Of course, he was my creation!" Loki sounded almost proud of this. After a moment, he added: "And my worst failure."

He didn't really sound too sad about it, though, at least in Adora's impression.

"And you have not learned anything from it? You are attempting to create another species based on our DNA?" Thor took a step toward his brother.

“No, I am attempting to restore our species to a viable state,” Loki spat. “To save us from extinction.”

“You think the High Council will accept your ‘solution’? You have not learned a thing from your past mistakes, then.”

“Uh… But that’s not true,” Entrapta cut in. “We - and that includes Loki - learned a lot from Horde Prime’s creation. And from Alpha’s data, of course. Learning from your mistakes is a core part of proper research! It’s the base of science!”

Both Asgard seemed confused for a moment.

“I don’t think he meant that,” Sam said.

“But he said so!”

“I think he was talking about the reasons and goals of experiments, not data,” Sam said.

“Oh!” Entrapta nodded. “But our goal is good - we want to save the Asgard! As long as we don’t cause any harm, we’re doing good, right?”

Adora nodded. Horde Prime had exterminated so many species, she wouldn’t let the Asgard vanish if she could help it. And she could. Well, her friends could. And she could help them.

“Just because your goal is good does not mean the means you use to achieve it are justified,” Thor said, nodding at Entratpa. “Something you never learned,” he added with a glare at Loki.

“But we’ve been teaching him that!” Entrapta objected. “We learned that ourselves.”

Thor shook his head. “You cannot trust him. As soon as he is faced with the choice to abandon his current plan or break whatever rules you set, he will choose the latter. He has proven that time and again.”

“Then we will ensure that this choice never happens.” Entrapta beamed at them. “Problem solved.”

Loki nodded in agreement, but Adora couldn’t help feeling that that wasn’t very reassuring.

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Samantha Carter refused to feel guilty. She had not promised Loki that they would keep his presence in Alpha a secret, nor had she been responsible for the decision to tell Thor the truth. Though she could stand behind that decision - trying to hide their involvement with Loki would only result in more trouble when it came out. Trouble for everyone - the Asgard wouldn’t trust them as allies, and they wouldn’t trust the cure they were researching either. Not easily, at least. Really, this was for the best. Of course, Loki couldn’t see it.

“You can say this now, but that is not something you can promise,” Thor said, looking at Entrapta. “If success solely depended on your will to succeed, we would have solved our problem long ago.”

Loki snorted at that. “So you say. But you and the rest of the High Council lost your resolve far too easily. Based on past experiences,” he added with a sneer.

“There were lines we were not willing to cross, and for a good reason. The risks were far too high - which was proven when you created Horde Prime, a scourge on the sector almost as bad as the Goa’uld,” Thor said.

“Worse actually,” Catra cut in. “More dangerous, at the very least - he had better tech than the Goa’uld.”

Loki nodded. “He was very skilled at acquiring and adapting our own technology.”

That’s a proud parent speaking, Sam thought. “He also destroyed an unknown number of planets and civilisations,” she added.

"Yes, he did. All in pursuit of his goal to rule the Galaxy - regardless of the fact that the sheer size of the galaxy made that goal impossible to achieve by any sane standard." Hordak spoke up. "He never let anything stop him."

"Until he met She-Ra," Catra said, flashing her fangs.

"Yes. Even Horde Prime had to bow to reality, and all the atrocities he committed did not reward him with success in the end," Thor said.

"I consider this comparison insulting," Loki replied. "I never tried to conquer a planet, much less a sector or the galaxy. Nor did I ever render any species extinct." He tilted his head. "Unless I had created it myself as part of my research."

Sam blinked. That sounded…

"You murdered a species you created?" Glimmer blurted out.

"Yes?" Loki looked confused for a moment. "It was not a sapient one," he quickly added. "Nor a very complex organism. It was merely meant as a proof of concept. And it failed."

"Still… creating life only to end it…" Entrapta shook her head. "Unless they were not viable, of course."

"I do not think they were competitive with other species in their ecological niche," Loki said. "But I never attempted it. Inserting them into an existing ecosystem would have been a risk I did not take."

"Ah, right. That's bad, yes." Entrapta nodded several times.

"You mean you did not do it *again*," Thor said. "You were not quite as cautious and diligent as you claim to be when you were experimenting with animals on Earth."

"All of them were unique specimens and, therefore, unable to procreate," Loki snapped back. "Even back then, I did not take

any such risks."

Sam somehow had her doubts.

"You experimented with animals?" Entrapta cocked her head.

"He created a monstrous snake and horse," Thor said. "And a wolf."

A snake, a horse and a wolf? Sam blinked. "Jörmungandr, Sleipnir and Fenrir?" she asked before she could stop herself. Daniel had given a briefing about the Norse myths after their first visit to Cimmeria.

"That is how the Tau'ri called them, yes," Thor said.

"Jörmungandr, Sleipnir and Fenrir?" Entrapta asked.

"The World Serpent, Odin's horse and the wolf that would kill Odin," Sam told her. "In Norse myths."

"Father was not amused about those animals. Or those stories," Thor said.

"I did not make up those stories," Loki said. "If Odin did not like them, he could have told the humans to change them."

"That was not our way. We already meddled too much with the Tau'ri," Thor retorted.

"See? Another pointless rule that only caused problems. Problems I get blamed for!"

"You were the one who created a giant snake, a monstrous wolf and an eight-legged horse that could barely walk, much less gallop!" Thor snapped back. "And then had them escape!"

"Oh! You created a new type of horse? Like Adora! She created a winged unicorn!" Entrapta beamed.

"And we won't ever let her forget it," Catra muttered.

Loki looked puzzled. “I didn't know you were a genetic engineer.”

Adora winced. “It was an accident.”

“You created a species by accident?” Thor stared at her. “No wonder you were willing to help Loki!”

“It was a magical accident, not an engineering, uh, project - I didn’t know what my power could do and hit a horse with magic by mistake.” Adora blushed, both from embarrassment and anger, Sam thought. “Anyway, I haven’t done that again.”

“Which you probably should,” Entrapta said. “Unless Swift Wind can procreate with normal horses, he will be the last of his species.”

“I don’t think we’re making the best impression on our visitor here,” the General commented in a whisper next to Sam.

She was forced to agree - Thor was staring at everyone as if he was expecting them to reveal abominations of science and magic.

If only Daniel were here.

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The Asgard Question Part 2

Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, November 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

This isn't going well, Catra thought. Not at all. Thor seemed to believe that they were as bad as Loki about research and things. Which, to be honest, wasn't entirely wrong given that they had almost destroyed Etheria during the Horde War because they - especially Catra and Glimmer - hadn't really been cautious enough. And Entrapta, for all that she was a great friend and good person, could leave a bad impression on people who met her for the first time. Or at a bad time. Not everyone understood that she wasn't like Loki, even if both were passionate scientists.

Thor was still shaking his head. "This is… It seems obvious why you are working with Loki."

"Because we both share the goal of saving the Asgard," Loki said.

"Because we both love science?" Entrapta cocked her head to the side and blinked.

"Because, apparently, you share the same appalling lack of caution and common sense when experimenting!" Thor snapped.

That was… well, also not entirely wrong, Catra had to admit. Not out loud, of course.

"That's not true!" Adora blurted out. "We're very careful - we have the entire base under close surveillance!"

"And it's on a moon, and we have sterilising protocols, so the chance of any organism escaping into the wild is very low," Entrapta added.

"I doubt that disinfectant would have stopped Horde Prime." Thor scoffed.

“I will not make that mistake again,” Loki said. “You still act as if I never learned from my mistakes.”

“That’s because you do not! Or if you learn something, it turns out to be the wrong lesson!” Thor shook his head. “You should not ask how to do something, but whether or not you should do something in the first place!”

“I will not let our species go extinct,” Loki said, glaring at his brother.

“Yes! We cannot let you die out if we can help it!” Entrapta chimed in before Thor could answer. “That wouldn’t be right! Too many species have already died out - with their entire worlds. And that doesn’t even cover the number of non-sapient species that are going extinct on Earth! We will save any species we can!”

“How the Asgard deal with our genetic degradation is *our* decision. You cannot decide for us,” Thor retorted.

“But Loki can! He is an Asgard himself,” Entrapta said.

Thor shook his head. “He is not even a member of the High Council any more. He has no authority. The fate of the Asgard will be decided by the High Council, not by a renegade and criminal.”

“As if the High Council has the knowledge and understanding to do what is necessary!” Loki scoffed.

“They are the rulers of the Asgard.”

“But you can’t force Loki to stop trying to save you; it’s his life as well that’s at stake,” Adora said. “No one has the authority to order people to let themselves die - or die out.”

“The High Council has the authority to set the law for the Asgard,” Thor told her. “And he has broken the law multiple times, severely. He is a criminal.”

“He’s willing to change,” Adora said.

Catra bit her lower lip to keep from saying anything.

“And he’s trying to save your species. Would you really rather die out than give him a chance?” Glimmer added.

“He had many chances and never took them.”

Thor was avoiding the question, Catra noted.

“I was held back,” Loki said. “And sabotaged by unjust and ignorant people who did not understand what I was doing.”

Thor scoffed. “We understood the results of your work perfectly. You have not changed.”

“You know,” Catra said, “if you judge people by their past, of course, you’ll never notice any change.”

Adora nodded with a beaming smile aimed at her, and Catra bit her lower lip again. She shouldn’t be arguing like this - she wasn’t any better than Loki. But she couldn’t just let Thor talk like… like Loki couldn’t change. Even though Catra still had her doubts about that herself.

“Why should my brother change now when he has never changed before?” Thor asked.

Because it sometimes takes a lot of wasted opportunities to overcome your pride, Catra didn’t say.

“Because now, we’re helping him,” Adora said.

“And do you expect me to forget his past deeds?” Thor turned to stare at Adora.

“If you cannot look to the future instead of to the past, you’ll never have a future,” Adora retorted.

“Those who forgot the past are doomed to repeat it,” Catra heard Jack whisper under his breath, followed by a hissed “Sir!” from

Sam.

“We don’t ask you to forget what he has done - but you should keep an open mind and give him a chance,” Bow chimed in.

“He had many chances,” Thor repeated himself. “Does he deserve another chance?”

“Are we talking about a chance to fix your genome?” Entrapta looked a little confused. “Because then, the answer is obviously ‘yes’ - if you have a problem, you research a solution until you find it.”

“Everyone deserves a chance to change,” Adora said. “No matter how many chances they have blown before.”

Catra felt a mix of love and shame at hearing Adora say that and couldn’t help blushing from both.

“Yes. This time, it will work,” Loki said. “I can feel it.”

Catra looked at him and, once more, felt doubt about his willingness to change.

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“Or that might be your breakfast disagreeing with your stomach.”

Jack O’Neill shrugged at the glances everyone was giving him. “Hey, just saying that a gut feeling isn’t exactly scientific.”

Catra snorted, as did Glimmer, and Bow tried his best not to grin, but the others kept frowning at him. Well, someone had to try and lighten the mood before Thor thought they were all like Loki. Which he probably thought already, to be honest.

“Well, no - at least I don’t think that anyone ever ran a study on gut feelings,” Entrapta said. “Unless it was about medical issues.”

“Well, I think with the return of magic, odds are a lot of such experiments were run,” Jack pointed out. “Or are still being run. People are trying to find ways to predict the future by using magic.” Despite all the warning tales about prophets and prophecies he had heard from Daniel. And the utter lack of any such magic spell or power on Etheria.

“Hm. Since Earth has different magical traditions compared to Etheria, that is a scientific approach.” Entrapta smiled at him.

Unfortunately, Thor wasn’t smiling. The Asgard was scowling at his brother. “You are dabbling with magic again?”

“I have not used magic in our experiments so far. Not only would that defeat the purpose of finding a cure our species can use without depending on others, but it has not been necessary so far.” Loki sniffed. “I have made significant progress with the support of these people - I am positive that this time, I can save the Asgard from our ancient folly.”

“Like you were positive the last time? And the time before that?”

“This is so much like you! To dismiss my claims without even attempting to verify them. How… unscientific!” Loki sniffed in return.

“Yes. If you don’t verify your data, how can you trust your decisions?” Entrapta asked. “Decisions based on prejudice are bad! And those based on gut feelings, I guess. Unless those experiments on Earth result in data that disproves this assumption.”

Thor looked more surprised than angry, at least for a moment. Then he shook his head. “Optimistic projections are not hard facts.”

“I’m not talking about projections!” Loki scoffed. “Take a look at the work I’ve already done!”

As if Alpha had been waiting for its cue - and it probably had, Jack realised - a holoprojection appeared next to the two Asgard, showing DNA sequences and several figures that looked like a mix between Asgard and humans. Which was a rather disturbing thought, actually, in light of Loki's comments about sexual reproduction.

"See? With the data and tools here, restoring our genome is within reach!" Loki crowed.

"What?" Thor bent forward and peered at the figures. "Those aren't depictions of our ancient forms!"

"Of course not!" Loki scoffed again. "Why should we regress to a state we left behind when we can evolve instead?"

Uh-oh. Carter had mentioned something about the project aiming for a new form or something, but hadn't that been because they didn't have the data to restore an older form? This sounded more like…

"You wish to shape our entire species according to your whim?" Thor all but bellowed. He looked at the text again. "Sexual reproduction?"

Loki - typically, Jack thought - was undaunted. "Of course. Asexual reproduction has proven to have played a part in causing our current crisis, while the vast majority of the sapient species we know reproduce sexually. That means that if we want to avoid suffering the same crisis later, we need to adapt - to evolve," he said in a voice that sounded far too smug to Jack.

And far too smug for Thor, it seemed. "You are mad if you believe that our people will accept such drastic changes!"

"Do you think they would rather die out instead?" Loki shot back.

"Some will, indeed, before suffering such… changes!" Thor spat.

“No one will be forced to change,” Loki said. “But our species will not go extinct.”

“That sounds as if you already have a contingency plan.” Thor managed to narrow his eyes quite impressively for their size. “I see. You claim you will not force your plan on others, yet what will you do if the Asgard would rather die out than accept such changes to our species?”

“That is none of your concern,” Loki said. “For you will have adapted and changed already or have died when the time comes for any such plan to be implemented.”

That sounded like a threat to Jack, but with the looming extinction of the Asgard, it might just be a factual statement.

Thor shook his head. “So, do you plan to repopulate our species? With your own?”

Loki frowned slightly at that, so Jack was sure that Thor had hit the nail on the head. “I will not let my people die out due to ignorance, false pride and superstition.”

“That is not your decision to make!” Thor told him.

“So, you think the High Council can order me to commit suicide? And to abstain from procreating?” Loki said. “And you call me unethical!”

Well, he had a point. Kind of - Jack didn’t like agreeing with Loki. But letting others, even your own government, decide whether or not you were allowed to have kids? That decision belonged to you, not to the government or anyone else. And, Jack added with a slight grimace, remembering his thoughts about his own sort of heritage, what with Anise’s proposals, so does the decision whether or not you would have kids. Which he wouldn’t, at least not now.

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That wasn't right! Adora shook her head. "You can't order your people - any of them - to die. Or die out. That's wrong!"

"One person cannot decide the fate of a species," Thor retorted.

"But the High Council can?" Loki asked, scoffing once more.

"The High Council, at least, is the legitimate authority of the Asgard! You are a renegade and criminal with no authority at all - and a history of failures and violations of our people's most important ethics. Your careless actions endangered the entire sector! If anyone is the least qualified to make any decisions about a species, it's you!" Thor glared at Loki.

"You would doom our people merely to obey pointless laws and customs that have long since lost their relevance! When a species faces an existential crisis, it must adapt, or it will die! You cannot cling to outdated morals when your very survival is at risk!" Loki spat.

Now that was… wrong as well. Adora shook her head. "No. In a crisis, it's most important to stick to your ideals."

"Yes," Bow chimed in while the two Asgard glared at each other. "If you abandon your ideals for convenience, did you ever have any ideals at all?"

Loki turned to face her. "If your ideals lead to your demise, then they are obviously not valid."

"Of course you would say that!" Thor shook his head. "Some ideals are worth more than your life! Some lines are so important that no price is worth crossing them. Not that you would understand that."

Adora nodded in agreement. With the principle, not the judgement of Loki. The ends didn't justify the means.

"Life means change. Adapt or die. Ideals are no exception," Loki retorted. "If upholding an ideal does more harm than good, it

needs to be changed. Anything else is stupid. Suicidally stupid if you are in lethal danger."

Adora glanced at the others. Catra had her lips pressed together as if she was forcing herself to remain silent. Glimmer looked… angry but torn?

"Very pragmatic," Jack said. "But who gets to decide what is more harm than good?"

Loki frowned at him. "It should be obvious that the survival of your species is paramount."

"No!" Thor retorted. "You are wrong. Our survival is not paramount. Not if it costs everything that makes us what we are. If we follow your plan, if we change like you want us to, then we will not be the Asgard any more. We are more than our genes - and you want to change those as well!"

"We changed more radically in the past," Loki spat. "Did we stop being Asgard then? Once, we sexually reproduced. Were we not Asgard back then? We had other ideals in the past, as you know - ideals we changed or dropped."

"We changed, but not for mere expediency or convenience!"

"This is about the survival of our species, not about mere convenience or expediency." Loki glared at his brother again. He hadn't actually stopped glaring for a while, Adora noted.

"No. This is about *you*, above all." Thor spread his hands and gestured at the holoprojections in front of him, then at the room. "This is about your ego. About you being proven right. About your will being enforced on the Asgard. If it were about the survival of our species, you would not go behind our back, you would not conspire to… to create a new species from our genes."

"I have tried working with you and the High Council! Multiple times! But I never succeeded because you are unwilling to do what must be done - or let me do it. You are so terrified of

change, you are dooming our species!" Loki took a step forward toward his brother.

"No! We are not terrified of change! We are horrified by the atrocities you did and would do in pursuit of your goals!" Thor stepped forward as well until he almost touched Loki. "And as I told you before: If you have to betray your ideals to survive, then that is too high a price to pay."

"For you. I am willing to pay this price. Future Asgard can choose their own ideals."

"Oh, you fool! You have not changed at all!" Thor turned away, then addressed Adora and her friends. "And you! You have seen how he thinks - that he will do anything, no matter how vile, to achieve his goals. How can you support him?"

Adora clenched her teeth, then took a deep breath and met Thor's eyes without flinching. "Because everyone deserves a chance to change. To do better. Because to deny Loki that would be betraying our ideals."

Thor stared at her for a moment without saying anything, then glanced at her friends. "I see. It's on your head, then." He nodded in. "I shall take my leave. The Asgard will not condone any of this."

Adora didn't think he was just talking about the experiments.

Glimmer nodded. "A shuttle will take you back to the Stargate."

As Thor left the room, Alpha leading him to the hangar, Adora couldn't help sighing.

"This could have gone better," Jack said, echoing her thoughts.

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"It could not," Loki said at once, scoffing. "My brother has always stubbornly clung to the High Council's rules and regulations in

blatant disregard of logic and rationality. He would never change. But, ultimately, his disapproval does not change anything."

You don't seem to be quite as nonchalant as you sound, Samantha Carter thought. She wasn't an expert in Asgard expressions and body language, but Loki looked tense, and there was a certain underlying frustration in his tone.

"I think that's what he said about you," the General commented.

"Yes. And it's wrong. People can change, even after a long time," Adora added.

People could, Sam agreed. Humans, at least. But the Asgard were not humans, and they lived a very long time - over a thousand years at the minimum since both Loki and Thor had been in contact with the Norse on Earth in the early Medieval Age. Who knew how old Loki and Thor were? Older people were often set in their ways. Of course, that might not apply to the Asgard. However, she couldn't deny that Thor hadn't seemed open to the idea that Loki had changed. Or would ever change.

"Thor is the Supreme Commander of the Asgard Fleet," Catra said. "And a member of your High Council, right?"

"To my current knowledge, yes," Loki replied.

"Does he speak for it?"

"I would say that Thor is one of the High Council's mouthpieces instead." Loki snorted. "As you have seen, he will obey them without question."

Sam's eyebrows rose. That sounded like a very biased opinion.

"Whatever," Catra said, shrugging. "The question is: What will the Asgard do now? Will they try to stop you?"

"They would love to." Loki grinned. "But they cannot afford a war with you, not when they are already fighting the Replicators. They

can harp and complain, but it will not amount to anything more than noise."

Sam wasn't about to dismiss diplomatic pressure as mere noise. Once again, she missed Daniel.

"The Asgard are a major power," Glimmer pointed out. "And we shouldn't dismiss them like that. There's more to power than just the military."

"And they won't be fighting the war against the Replicators forever - they are winning, after all," Catra added.

"By the time the war ends, I will have completed my research," Loki retorted. "The deed will have been done, so to speak."

That sounded very confident. Maybe overly so. But neither Morrison nor Entrapta seemed to disagree with the assessment. Then again, both were a little quiet - understandable with Morrison; he wasn't used to interstellar diplomacy. But Entrapta usually spoke her mind, often without regard to the situation at hand. Sam knew that from experience.

"And then what?" Adora asked. "What will you do?"

"I will save the Asgard. I will offer the cure to my people," Loki said. "They deserve a choice. A chance to change and survive as a species."

"And what will you do if they refuse it?" The General shrugged at Loki's frown. "Sometimes, people act irrationally. They might not want a new body even if it's far superior to their old one."

Loki scoffed. "While I cannot deny that some of the Asgard might baulk at the idea of such a change - my foolish brother is one example of that backward thinking - that does not extend to everyone. Our numbers aren't what they were in the past, but even a fraction of the Asgard joining me will be enough to restore us in the long term since we will be able to reproduce again."

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded. “And even if all Asgard refuse, you just need enough genetic diversity to avoid inbreeding, and that won’t need too many samples - we can introduce variations here as well.”

“Exactly!” Loki smiled. “In the worst case, I can restore the Asgard myself.”

Just like Thor had feared.

“Sounds like a copyright complaint waiting to happen. Does Bright Moon have copyright lawyers?”

The General was joking, but this was an issue. “How would the Asgard react to that?” Sam asked. She couldn’t imagine that they would be happy about Loki’s plans. Thor certainly had said so.

Loki frowned. “I would hope that their foolish pride will not push them into an attempt to genocide the new generation of Asgard, but in light of my experience with the High Council - and Thor’s stated views, which you witnessed - I cannot exclude the possibility.”

That sounded a bit far-fetched to Sam.

“We won’t let them - or anyone - murder your children!” Adora, of course, jumped at it.

“They would have to attack the Clones as well if they wanted to destroy all your children,” Entrapta pointed out. “But they wouldn’t do that, would they? Thor didn’t seem to have issues with you.” She looked at Hordak.

“I doubt that he would have announced a desire or plan to kill us all in our presence,” Hordak said. “However, I don’t know if he has fully considered the implications of our creation - that we are, technically, your descendants.” He nodded at Loki. “Or what the rest of your High Council will think about this. Us. He has known we are related to the Asgard since we first met, though.”

Sam agreed. Thor had only discovered Loki's involvement today, but he might have already suspected something.

"But…" Entrapta shook her head several times. "Why would he want to murder you? That would make no sense! The Asgard protect people from the Goa'uld!"

Sam bit her lower lip. Her friend was getting worked up about this entirely hypothetical threat. An entirely hypothetical threat, she realised, that Loki had brought up. And which would make sure that the Etherians would support and protect him at any cost…

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Catra frowned at Loki. He 'couldn't exclude' the possibility of the Asgard attempting to murder all Clones? If the Asgard tried that, it would mean war. And he had said they were unlikely to start a war while fighting the Replicators. But the possibility alone - pure speculation - had Adora up in arms. Which was awfully convenient for Loki. Of course, they didn't know much about the Asgard; they had only met Thor and Loki, and you shouldn't judge an entire species after meeting only two of them - imagine if someone had met Shadow Weaver and Double Trouble and thought all Etherians were backstabbing bastards like them! But the Asgard were protecting at least some planets from the Goa'uld, and Thor had taken the revelation that Hordak and the other clones were closely related to the Asgard, enough to fool some of their Asgard's own defence systems, without much of a reaction. He had only lost his temper once he had discovered Loki had created Horde Prime.

She cocked her head to the side and snorted. "I don't think we should assume the worst about the Asgard just because Thor doesn't like Loki."

"Of course not," Adora agreed.

"They have been protecting people from the Goa'uld," Bow added. "Without exploiting them, as far as we can tell."

"They did pose as gods, though," Jack pointed out.

Teal’c nodded.

“Yes, but…Thor said that was a mistake, and they did it to avoid, uh, influencing their culture?” Bow shrugged. “They don’t rule them or demand worship, that much we know.”

“True.” Teal’c nodded again.

“And Thor didn’t make an issue about the Clones even after he knew you were related,” Catra pointed out, nodding at Hordak. “He only got mad at you, Loki.”

“Based on prejudices,” Loki said.

“Well, he must have suspected you before,” Jack added. “He mentioned scientists breaking their laws when we met him.”

Loki sneered. “The High Council would blame me without any proof.”

Not without reason, Catra thought. Loki must have done some really nasty things in the past for that. “He does seem a bit fixated on you,” she said. “Were you close before you became enemies?” She noticed Adora and the others glancing at her but ignored them. Being siblings didn’t mean you had to be close - they didn’t know much about Asgard society.

“We are brothers,” Loki said. “We grew up together. We worked together. But when I needed his support the most, he betrayed me to the High Council.”

Catra suppressed a wince. She knew that feeling. Very, very well. But she also knew that feeling betrayed didn’t mean you were in the right. Not at all. “And ever since then, you’ve worked to show him how wrong he was?”

“If he were objective, he would have admitted his mistake,” Loki replied. “But no matter what I did, he opposed me - sometimes ruined my work. I fear that he will deny I was right even after I save our species.”

Ah, yes. That sounded very familiar. Uncomfortably so. Catra nodded. “And it was never your fault?”

“Of course not! I only did what needed to be done to save our species!” Loki spat. “But he does not want to understand that the High Council is wrong and would doom us all!”

Catra glanced at Adora. Her lover was wincing. And so were Glimmer and Bow. And they weren’t looking at Catra. Pointedly so.

“Well, we won’t let them doom your species!” Entrapta said. “And then you can make up with your brother.”

Loki nodded.

Did he really think that would work? And did he really care so much for Thor’s acceptance? Or was it, as Thor had claimed, just about being right? Was this about his pride above all? Catra knew how that felt as well. It had been her lowest point, well, one of them, when she had risked Etheria’s destruction just to win against Adora.

On the other hand, Loki was trying to save his species. If the High Council really preferred dying out to changing, even radically changing, then they were being stupid and had no right to drag others down with them.

Catra shrugged. Ultimately, Loki’s relationship with Thor wasn’t any of her business. As long as it didn’t cause a war or something. “I think that will take more than being right, but he’s your brother, not mine.”

“Whatever.” Glimmer shook her head. “In any case, we need to ensure that the Asgard won’t attack us. We can’t launch an offensive against the Goa’uld if we have to guard against them.”

“And we should explain to the High Council that our experiments are safe,” Entrapta added. “They don’t have to fear us.”

Loki snorted at that. “They fear what they cannot control.”

"They must fear a lot, then," Teal'c commented. "Most of the Universe is outside of anyone's control."

Jack frowned. "I'm not sure how welcome we'll be in their space. Thor seemed pretty pissed off that we were working with Loki."

Catra could understand that as well.

"Yes," Adora said. "But we still have to reach out to him. And we need to find out what the rest of the High Council thinks."

"And we need Daniel," Jack said.

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Mojave Desert, California, United States of America, November 20th, 1999

Jack O'Neill wasn't sure what had been going through Daniel's head when he had picked a retreat in the Mojave Desert to help Sha're recover from being a Goa'uld host. Did he think it would look familiar to her? Jack doubted that. "At least it's not summer," he muttered as he brought his personal stealth shuttle to a stop next to what looked like a rather cheap bungalow.

Since landing and leaving indents in the ground from the shuttle's struts would defeat the purpose of using a stealth shuttle in the first place, he left it hovering with its rear facing the door, then quickly lowered the ramp and stepped out.

By the time he rang the door, the ramp had been retracted, and the shuttle was invisible again. And the two undercover security watching over his friend and Sha're he had made had stopped staring at him.

"Coming!" he heard from inside the bungalow. A moment later, the door was opened, and Daniel smiled at him. "Hi, Jack."

"Hi, Daniel." Jack made a point of looking his friend over. Civilian shirt, jeans, liht shoes, messy hair, no harried expression or

tension… Daniel looked like he was doing fine in the retreat. And Jack felt a slight pang of guilt for what he was about to do.

"Jack O'Neill. Welcome." Sha're joined Daniel, half a step behind him, one hand on his shoulder. She was wearing a simple dress and sandals and looked better than the last time Jack had seen her, but she was tense - and her eyes kept looking around, past him and back to the bungalow's living room.

"Hi, Sha're." Jack did his best to smile reassuringly at her. "How are you doing?"

"I am doing… well," Sha're said.

Jack would have believed it if not for the slight hesitation. And the way Daniel put his hand on hers and gently squeezed.

"Come in!" His friend took a step back, wrapping an arm around Sha're's waist, and gestured towards the living room with his free hand.

"Thank you."

The bungalow looked nicer on the inside. Probably refurbished by Uncle Sam in a hurry after their return from Saqqara, and the outside had been left alone because it would draw less attention. "Nice digs," Jack said as he sat down on the chair next to the couch.

"Yes," Daniel said. "The Air Force is being generous. Or the Alliance - I don't actually know who's paying for this."

Jack shrugged - he didn't know either. "It doesn't matter; it's still the least that you deserve for everything you've done for Earth."

Sha're appeared, carrying a tray with three glasses, three bottles of beer and a plate with olive oil, salt and flatbread that looked like it was homemade. She put it down on the low table, then sat next to Daniel on the couch. So close, Jack would have trouble sliding a sheet of paper between them.

"Thank you," he told her as Daniel opened the beers. It was some German brand Jack didn't know - it wasn't sold in the Lübtheen Base. It did look expensive, though.

"They sell them in California," Daniel said, smiling a little embarrassedly. He must have caught Jack studying the label.

"If they had to fly it in from Germany itself, it would still be fine - you deserve this and more," Jack told him.

Daniel shrugged.

"Daniel told me about this beer, back home. He did not lie about its taste. It's very different from what we have at home, but very good," Sha're said as she filled her glass.

Daniel did the same. Jack would have preferred to drink from the bottle, but when in Rome… "Cheers!"

The beer was good. "I'll have to order some for the base," Jack said, holding up the bottle, before he tried the bread. Yes, definitely homemade. "Did you make this?" he asked Sha're as he dipped another piece into the oil. "It's great."

She tilted her head slightly. "I am learning how to use the… appliances." With a wry smile, she added: "The first tries were… not so good."

"They were good," Daniel insisted at once. "Much better than what bread we get here."

Sha're smiled and nodded, but it looked as if she didn't believe him. Jack studied her while he grabbed another piece of flatbread and refilled his glass. She looked… fragile would be wrong. But she wasn't at ease. That was understandable, of course, with what she had gone through, but being on Earth would be a shock under the best circumstances. "So, enjoying the desert?" he said.

"It's nice," Daniel said. "Quiet. Peaceful."

"It reminds me of home. A little," Sha're added.

"Well, we couldn't take you to Egypt," Jack said.

"Daniel explained that, yes."

"I would have loved showing you the country where the Stargate was found, but… Politics make that difficult," Daniel said.

"I understand. I have… seen the news." She nodded at the television in the corner. "It was a little scary."

And coming from a woman who had been the host of a Goa'uld queen, that said a lot about the news.

"Yes." Daniel nodded again, finished his beer, then gently took Sha're's hand again. "Anyway, Jack, while I know you'd use a stealth shuttle just to come visit, you didn't come just to visit, did you?"

Jack felt guilty again. He grimaced, then slowly nodded. "Yes. I didn't come just to check up on you. We - the Alliance - have a bit of a problem."

"And you need my help." Daniel tilted his head a bit to the side, glancing at Sha're. He hadn't let go of her hand, Jack noted.

"Well… You're our foremost expert in alien diplomacy," Jack said.

"I'm not a diplomat, Jack. I'm an archaeologist."

Was that modesty or an excuse to let them down? Probably the former; Jack knew Daniel had never shied away from helping those in need. On the other hand, Sha're needed him right now, and he hadn't yet asked what the problem was… "I guess someone forgot to tell that to all the aliens we met," Jack said, grinning.

Daniel frowned a little but nodded. "Well, someone had to talk to people. But our actual diplomats have been in contact with Etheria

for over a year now. And also with the Tok'ra. And academics of all kinds have been analysing alien cultures." He nodded at a stack of magazines next to the couch.

He was right, of course. But none of them was Daniel.

"And the Etherians have diplomats as well," Daniel went on. "They have had global diplomatic meetings, formal ones, for centuries, and they've been dealing with people different enough they could arguably be aliens - although I guess that their cultures did share basic similarities, which would not be the same with actual alien cultures. On the other hand, we mostly talked to human cultures, so it's not that different compared to Earth's experiences."

Jack nodded. "Yeah. But none of our diplomats have made first contact as often as you did. Or at all. It's not about knowing how to behave at a state dinner or making nice with people you hate - it's about understanding aliens. And having an open mind." He looked straight at Daniel. "And most importantly, it's about being honest."

His friend blinked, then frowned. "OK, what exactly did the Alliance diplomats do, and why didn't Adora and Glimmer straighten them out yet?"

Jack winced. "Thor found out about the deal with Loki."

"Oh."

"Loki… the alien you mentioned trying to save his species?" Sha're asked.

"Yes." Daniel nodded at her.

That was a correct description, but one that left out a lot of stuff. "Thor had found some clues that Loki was interested in Earth and came to warn us," Jack went on. "

"Oh." Daniel winced. "And then he found out that we're working with Loki."

“Who apparently is Asgard’s most wanted mad scientist,” Jack said, smiling wryly. “And he and Thor have some issues with each other. Big ones.” And maybe a subscription to ‘Sibling Problems Weekly’.

“And Adora and the others couldn’t explain the situation?” Daniel cocked his head to the side, frowning again.

“They did their best, but…” Jack sighed. “Thor didn’t exactly agree with the whole ‘even war criminals get a second chance if they say they’re sorry’ stance of the Etherians.”

Daniel frowned some more and pushed his glasses up his nose with one finger. “That’s an unfair view, Jack. The Etherians do not see things the same as we do - they have entirely different traditions for settling conflicts, at least compared to modern Earth, and their culture focuses a lot more on personal relationships between rulers.”

Jack managed not to grin - Daniel starting to lecture was a good sign. “Well, as we found out, the Asgard don’t share those traditions, and Thor’s focus on the personal relationship with his brother the mad scientist didn’t go over well with the Etherians. And vice versa. So…” He spread his hands. “Thor also didn’t like the idea that Loki’s trying to build the future of the Asgard, including their body and sexuality.”

“Their sexuality?” Daniel blinked.

“I thought they didn’t have sex - they grow bodies like plants,” Sha’re said, frowning.

“Well, yeah, they do, but Loki thinks that’s part of their problem, and so he’s trying to change it. Make them more like us.” Jack snorted. “Literally - he wants to know more about how we handle sex and what we find attractive in a partner.”

Daniel blinked, his mouth half-open. Sha’re seemed surprised as well, but less so.

“Anyway,” Jack said, “Thor didn’t leave on good terms, and no one knows what the Asgard will do now. That Horde Prime was Loki’s creation doesn’t help at all, of course.”

Daniel slowly nodded. “Thor should have realised that after our second meeting since they scanned Hordak. But… maybe Thor didn’t want it to be true? Or maybe there were other possibilities?”

“He wasn’t aware that Loki created Horde Prime. He thought Loki just helped with the clones,” Jack explained.

“Ah.” Daniel nodded once more. “That would fit. But that would also make things worse - another thing that Loki did that caused a lot of harm. Indirectly, but still.”

“You’ve found the crux of the problem.” As expected.

Daniel gave him a look that told Jack he had been a bit too obvious with the flattery. Even though it was the truth. “Anyway, that’s the kind of mess we’re dealing with.”

“And you want my help with it.” Daniel glanced at Sha’re again, this time with a guilty expression.

And Jack felt guilty again. “Maybe look the files over and give us a bit of advice? You more than deserve your time off, and you’re dealing with a lot.” He shrugged. That wouldn’t be enough, though. Daniel was best when he was talking to people.

“And the Etherians trust me, while they wouldn’t trust a diplomat. Not as much,” Daniel said.

“Yes.” Though Jack, Carter and Teal’c all had also agreed that Daniel was the best choice. For mostly the same reasons. They knew and trusted him. With their lives, if necessary.

“And they are right,” Sha’re said.

Jack blinked, and so did Daniel. “Sha’re…” His friend trailed off.

Sha’re smiled at Daniel. “This is important. For everyone. For the war against the Goa’uld.” She bared her teeth for a moment, and Daniel wrapped one arm around her again. “And you won’t be gone - you can… commute?”

“Yes, commute.” Daniel smiled.

“Or we can go to your house. See more of Earth.”

Jack knew that Daniel hadn’t spent much time in his nominal home in Colorado since the Stargate had been moved to Canada and the Alliance had been installed in Brussels. But there was no need to bring that up. Hell, if Daniel wanted a villa in Belgium - or anywhere else - and a personal shuttle with pilot, he’d get them in a heartbeat. It would be a drop in the budget for the Alliance. And Daniel had more than earned it.

Anything to get his friend on the job. But they better look out for Sha’re as well. And separating them… “You can help him,” he said, looking at her.

She seemed surprised for a moment. Then pensive. “I have seen a lot. Much of it was…” She pressed her lips together. “But some was useful.”

Daniel hugged her, then glared at Jack. “You don’t have to do this. You already got debriefed. And that was…”

That wouldn’t have been pretty, no. Jack could imagine. But he also could imagine that doing something to help the war against the Goa’uld, or just doing something, would help Sha’re.

And, ultimately, it was her decision.

Especially if it helps fix the mess with the Asgard, he thought. And felt a pang of guilt again.

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The Asgard Question Part 3

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 21st, 1999

Daniel and Sha’re shouldn’t have come. They should have stayed in their retreat in the desert until Sha’re was over her ordeal. They had been separated for years; it was only fair that they could be together, just the two of them, as long as they wanted now.

And yet, Adora couldn’t say this. It would make her a hypocrite - she hadn’t said anything when Jack had announced that he would go and ask Daniel to help them. Well, she had voiced some concern, but she hadn’t stopped him.

So she smiled at the two when they entered the meeting room. “Hi, Daniel! Hi, Sha’re! Jack!”

Catra just waved from where she was sitting - and she had once again propped her feet on the table!

“Hi, Adora.” Daniel smiled and nodded at them.

“Hello.” Sha’re sounded a little shy. And she was avoiding Adora’s eyes - no, she was looking around in the room. “This is your office?”

“Ah, no, that’s a meeting room. I was just doing some work here while waiting for you,” Adora explained. And then wanted to wince - this sounded like Daniel and Sha’re should have hurried.

“It’s her second office, actually,” Jack said. “Not officially, but she’s so often in here, they stopped using it for anything else.”

Adora winced at that. She had noticed that the minibar had been stocked with all the drinks she and the others preferred, and this was the meeting room they always used for, well, meetings with their friends, but… “Really? Shouldn’t I have been told that?” Or asked, actually?

"It's the mark of a good staff and aide that such things are done without bothering the commander. It's not your job to worry about your office," Jack said.

"Yeah." Catra agreed. "Let people do their job and do yours." She flashed her fangs and added: "Unless they screw up, of course. Then, you need to straighten them out. But they've been doing well so far."

Adora frowned at her lover. That was… well, not wrong, but the way she said it was not too nice. But they had other things to worry about than their offices. Though if this was her meeting room, then maybe she could get a few things installed that would… Later, she reminded herself. "Anyway, please sit down. And thank you for interrupting your vacation."

Daniel shrugged. "Jack was very persuasive."

What? She glared at Jack. "He said he would ask you if you could help us!"

"Hey! That's what I did!" Jack pouted for a moment, then frowned at Daniel. "I didn't push you!"

Daniel grinned in return. "I didn't say that. But you did lay out our problems with the Asgard quite clearly. And it seems our relations with them are currently strained."

"Well, so it seems," Adora agreed. "We don't actually know what they will do. Or think of us." Though they had some ideas…

"But Thor was pissed when he left, and not without reason," Catra added.

"So I've heard. And I've read the reports on our flight here," Daniel said. He sighed. "I am not sure if things would have gone differently if I had been there. Both Thor and Loki seemed set in their views."

“But they’re brothers!” Adora protested. They just needed to realise that! “Thor is biased against Loki because of their past, but both want what’s best for their species.”

“But they don’t agree on what’s best for the Asgard,” Daniel retorted. “In fact, Thor seems to think that Loki’s vision would be a catastrophe even if Loki succeeded. So, it’s not just about Loki’s past, uh, deeds. Misdeeds.”

“You mean his crimes,” Catra cut in. “We did catch him trying to fake a Replicator outbreak to fool the rest of the Asgard, remember?”

Yes, Adora knew that. Loki had tried to trick his people. That wasn’t very remorseful - but he was desperate to save his species.

“Yes. And Thor and the other Asgard remain unaware of that,” Daniel said.

Catra nodded. “If Thor knew about that, he probably would’ve been angrier.”

“I’m not sure it would have mattered - he was already fuming,” Jack said.

“You can always get angrier,” Catra objected. “He wasn’t attacking us or swearing vengeance or anything.”

Adora sighed. That was another secret that would cause trouble when it would be revealed. “We should never have hidden that we’re working with Loki.”

“We don’t have a duty to tell the Asgard everything,” Catra said. “It’s not as if they told us anything.”

“But this concerns them,” Adora pointed out.

“We don’t know what they do that might concern us.” Catra shrugged. “They do control planets with humans who were taken from Earth. You could argue that that is not very honest either.”

"You could, but pointing out wrongs on the other side doesn't often help with making things right," Daniel said. "Sometimes, not even when you do it to help fix what's wrong. Certainly not when it's used to defend your own faults."

Adora nodded. That was true!

"So, what do you suggest? Sell out Loki?" Catra asked. "That would be breaking our deal with him."

"We won't do that to him! He was dealing in good faith with us!" Adora protested.

"As far as we know," Jack said.

And Catra nodded. As did Sha're, who had been very quiet so far.

Adora frowned. They couldn't assume the worst of everyone!

Daniel cleared his throat. "There's a few things we need to consider - and we need to talk to Loki. I think."

*****

Research Station Alpha, The First Moon of Enchantment, November 22nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"I fail to see why you should even entertain the notion of contacting the Asgard again before we have finished our project. My stubborn brother has made his opinion clear, and experience proves he will not budge."

Samantha Carter rolled her eyes at Loki's words. It wasn't very diplomatic, but she didn't care any more. He had exhausted her patience.

"His opinion, which was clearly influenced by his personal, ah, issues with you," Daniel said - Loki hadn't exhausted his patience. "We don't know that the High Council shares it."

“He would not dare eat a meal without the permission of the High Council, much less refuse the salvation of our species without the High Council’s agreement.” Loki sniffed. “I’ve told you this before.”

“Yes, but how can he know what the High Council will think when they have not yet been informed about this project? By now, he will have told them, of course, but back then, he had not yet been able to do that, so he was acting based on assumptions - and you told us yourself that his assumptions were wrong, didn’t you?” Daniel smiled.

“I did, but that was about his assumptions about me, not about the High Council.” Loki sounded petulant.

“And yet, both are assumptions.” Daniel shrugged. “In any case, I doubt that it will do any harm if we contact the Asgard. Any additional harm, at least.”

“They might construct this as another attempt to interfere with their precious Asgard destiny and take offence.” Loki sneered.

If Sam hadn’t already known that he had deeply-rooted issues with his brother and the High Council, and probably the rest of the Asgard as well, this would prove it. Loki was usually at least acting calm and collected, in control of everything. Now, he was showing more emotions in a day than he had during all of her visits before put together.

“That wouldn’t make any sense!” Entrapta protested. “We have only talked to you and Thor, so it’s just logical that we would want another opinion to ensure we have all the data we need to make a decision about the Asgard.”

“Unfortunately, many of those who should be making decisions based on rational thinking seem to lack the capacity for it,” Hordak commented.

“Exactly!” Loki nodded sharply. “My former peers are letting their emotions rule them! And base emotions such as fear and pride, at that!”

Look who's talking, Sam thought. Out loud, she said: "They are acting based on past experience. That's not irrational."

"It's science," Entrapta agreed. "Unless you're unwilling to alter your views based on new data. Then you're not acting like a scientist should."

"Exactly!" Loki repeated himself. "In the past, my projects failed due to lack of support. This time, with your support, I will succeed!"

At least you didn't say: 'I cannot fail, only be failed!', Sam thought. But based on Loki's past comments, that was likely what he felt.

"So we hope," Daniel said with a smile.

Sha're, though, who had been silent until now, shook her head. "Failure is always possible. Something that the false gods often fail to accept or understand."

"Do not compare me to those parasites! They are mere scavengers, stealing the technology of their betters to fool the gullible into worshipping them as gods!" Loki hissed.

To Sam's surprise, Sha're didn't flinch. "If you don't want me to compare you to them, do not act in a way that reminds me of them." She looked at Daniel. "The Tau'ri and the Etherians are helping you. They are even risking a conflict with your own people for you. The least you can do to repay them is to show some respect for those not so fortunate. The followers of the false gods are not gullible - they have been raised from childhood to worship them as gods. That is not something you easily overcome."

Loki scoffed. "To mistake mere technology - and often not very impressive technology at that - for supernatural or divine power is the sign of a… naive mind."

"That is not true," Daniel interjected, a bit more sharply than Sam was used to from him. "You cannot expect people who have never been taught science to question their beliefs when they have no

reason to do so. The Goa'uld posing as gods act exactly like the gods they pose as are said to act. By now, they have been able to mould their follower's faith. Their dogmas have been entrenched for millennia. This kind of conditioning cannot easily be overcome. You would need to teach them about technology first and show them that what they consider divine power is something they could duplicate with the right tools - and that requires a lot of effort as well."

Loki scoffed. "That may be so, but the High Council has no such excuse. They were not raised in ignorance, yet revel in it anyway."

"Then that is one more reason to contact them," Daniel said. "How can we hope that they will change their opinion if we do not give them the opportunity to learn more?"

Loki glared at him. He really couldn't stand losing, whether an argument or anything else, Sam thought.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 23rd, 1999

"...and the police have not yet commented on whether or not they will resume the investigation. While no sign of foul play has been discovered, several relatives of Jones want the authorities to investigate 'curses and other foul magic', claiming that the pile-up near Dallas wasn't caused by Jones' 'brake-checking' a truck but 'evil outside interference'. The new Attorney General of Texas hasn't commented on the case yet, though, with the autopsy results showing that Jones was inebriated at the time of the accident, it seems unlikely that they will resume the investigation."

"Thank you, Carl. While the Dallas case seems like a non-starter, it is not the only case where the police are faced with claims that magic was used in a harmful way. With increasing signs that Earth's magic tradition is not quite as flashy as Etheria's, many people are afraid that what would have been dismissed as mere

bad luck or a wrong decision a year ago is actually the result of a witch using magic to curse or beguile someone. According to the latest count, three prominent divorce cases are claiming that the alleged infidelity was actually caused by magic influence, and the number of reports that claim someone was 'roofied with magic' is growing quickly. Some politicians are already calling for literal witch-hunts, despite the…"

Catra rolled her eyes and switched channels. "Took them long enough to find new excuses for their own faults," she muttered as a laundry ad started to play.

"What did you say?" Adora asked, looking up from her magazine.

"They're blaming 'witches' for their problems," Catra said. "If nothing's done about this, we might see witch-hunts in the Alliance." Too many other countries already had those - mainly but not limited to those where religious fanatics were in power.

"What?" Adora frowned. "That would go against all agreements! And their own laws!"

Catra shrugged. "Not if they claim they're just investigating criminals. And it's not completely impossible that someone is using magic to hurt someone." If you had the talent and felt you were hurt, why not strike back?

"But…" Adora blinked. "They don't have the sorceresses to investigate such things. How could they tell if magic was used without someone who can do magic?"

"According to the news, by questioning the suspects until they confess. I don't think they mean torture like in the old witch-hunts, but…" Catra shrugged again. Between the religious fanatics who hated all magic and the idiots who thought this was a great opportunity to blame others for their actions, and the examples from other countries…

"We need to do something about this," Adora said, frowning as she put down her magazine and got up from the couch to get

back to her desk.

And now I've ruined your break! Catra thought, pressing her lips together.

"...has voiced concerns about the continued growth of the worship of She-Ra. While the movement is most numerous in India, where a small minority claims she should be part of the Hindu pantheon, calls for her canonisation have also been heard in Europe, even though the Vatican has firmly opposed any such proposals. In the Middle East, several fatwas have been issued that…"

Yeah, no, this wasn't the time to tease Adora about her church. Catra switched channels again.

"...and the latest statistics show a concerning trend that, while currently overshadowed by the shift to a war economy, might lead to significant problems in the future as entire industries are rendered obsolete by advanced technology and magic. But it's not all doom and gloom - many experts think that the vast number of underdeveloped planets that are currently controlled by the Goa'uld represents an untapped potential market that will be a boost to…"

"That's what we need," Catra muttered. "Earth colonising the galaxy." Or was that neo-colonising? Was that a word? She snorted and pushed the button again.

"...have vetoed another resolution that condemned the Etherians for their 'aggressive violation of the sovereignty of other countries in a blatant attempt to enforce their imperialistic values on Earth'. Though the widening gap, both in political values and power, between the countries that joined or are associated with the Alliance and the countries that are not part of it, is a concern that needs to be addressed by the United Nations. If the majority of the countries are effectively at the mercy of the West, then that will have repercussions for the entire world and…"

“We need more sorceresses,” Adora interrupted the next ad on the television in her office - Earth had way too many of them, and they were far too repetitive once the novelty had worn off, in Catra’s opinion. And it had worn off long ago. “Earth needs to be able to investigate and disprove such claims about curses - and deal with the actual curses.”

“Send a memo to Castaspella?” Catra suggested. “They might have some sorceresses who don’t want to fight in the war but wouldn’t mind police work.” Not many, though. Not nearly enough.

“That won’t be enough. We need sorceresses from Earth.” Adora nodded. “We need a training program that actually works. Sending a few students to Mystacore is not enough.”

And that was still just in the start-up phase, anyway. “Tell Glimmer to handle it,” Catra told her lover. “Between her, Micah and Castaspella, they should be able to figure things out.” She didn’t add: ‘You have other things to do’, but she was sure Adora understood it anyway.

Judging by the way Adora pouted at Catra, she did.

*****

“Hello, Jack!”

“Hello, Anise.” Jack O’Neill nodded at the Tok’ra as he entered the meeting room. “Entrapta.”

“Hi, Jack!” Entrapta waved at him with her air, nose buried in a tablet in front of her, with two keyboards held by her hair at her sides.

Anise’s stance shifted slightly, and Jack knew she was releasing control before she spoke in Freya’s voice: “Hello, Jack.”

“And hi, Freya.” He nodded again. Polite and friendly. The Tok’ra were allies. And Freya was a lovely woman and not quite as

focused on having his baby as her counterpart. Her interest in him would have been flattering - but still not wanted - if she weren't a host to a snake.

"How are you doing?"

He shrugged. "Oh, you know - the usual. Kicking Goa'uld ass, dealing with paperwork…"

Freya laughed, but it was Anise who answered. "I see. Entrapta has been filling me in on the progress of her cloning research."

"Yes!" Entrapta looked up. "Unfortunately, it's not very useful for the Tok'ra since they need sapient hosts, not just bodies, and we haven't yet solved how to transfer someone's consciousness into a new body, like the Asgard do. Horde Prime knew how to do it - probably better than the Asgard since he did it so quickly and so often, but we lack data about the Asgard's process, except for some comments from Loki, which seem to indicate that it's not a short or easy process. Unfortunately, Horde Prime's data was lost when Adora turned his flagship into a plant, and the Clones didn't know anything about it. They haven't been interested in restoring it, anyway - which is kinda understandable, but still a loss for science. I could ask Loki, I guess, but if he told us how the Asgard do it, then the Asgard might get more annoyed with us and him for taking their secrets or something. Anyway, that's what we're currently doing!"

Jack blinked and tried to digest all that. "So… you're trying to transfer minds?"

Entrapta nodded. "Well, that would be the goal. Though we probably shouldn't do that unless we're sure it won't have side effects on us. We don't know everything we need to know about a person's consciousness yet. I mean, we know how the brain works, and the memories, but we're not sure if that's all or if there's more. Like, can you copy someone's consciousness into a new body and have a copy of the person? Or would something be missing? Or is your consciousness unique, and you can only

transfer it but not copy it?" Entrapta shrugged. "I can think of a few experiments that would help with finding out more about it, but they're kinda… questionable?" She cocked her head to the side.

"Questionable?" Anise asked, raising her eyebrows.

"Well, what if something goes wrong, and we lose the consciousness we want to copy? Or it suffers data loss during the process? It's a very delicate process. And what about magic? Is that tied to your consciousness, or is it tied to your genes? What if your new body lacks the talent? And what if you can copy a consciousness but not their powers?"

"Or what if you *can* copy someone?" Jack said, smiling thinly and trying not to show his actual thoughts about the whole idea. "Multiple times?"

"Oh!" Entrapta perked up.

"And what about their friends and lovers?" Jack went on before Entrpata could get carried away.

She blinked again, looking at him with her mouth open. "Oh. Yeah, I guess that would be… weird. And a problem."

"I concur. The implications of duplicating someone, and the effects of such actions on their relationships, and society in general, seems rather complicated," Anise said.

"That's one way to say it," Jack said.

"Maybe we should ask Loki if the Asgard have tried that," Entrapta suggested.

"I think we don't want two or more Lokis," Jack said. He could imagine Thor's reaction.

"But they must have thought about it - it's kind of obvious, isn't it?" Entrapta said.

"It might be a cultural taboo - or there might be, as you speculated, reasons why you cannot copy people," Anise said.

That was above his pay grade. Or should be. Jack shook his head. "Best not to rock the boat. We're still dealing with the problems caused by Loki's research into new bodies for the Asgard." And he didn't want to know how the rest of the Alliance and Earth as a whole, would react to Entrapta's speculation about copying people.

Though he'd have to check with Carter about all of this. She would know just how likely all of this speculation was.

And speak of the devil… Carter, Teal'c, Daniel and Sha're entered the room, interrupting the disturbing discussion. Jack checked his watch as greetings were exchanged. Adora, Catra, Glimmer and Bow were still not here for the meeting with Anise. And while arriving just on time was something Catra did, Adora usually was always early. And overprepared, of course. And Glimmer or Bow were never late when they could help it.

So, something was probably up on Etheria.

*****

"Hello, everyone!" Adora said. She smiled at the others in the room, feeling slightly embarrassed for almost being late. But their discussion about magical training had gone on for a bit longer than expected. And hadn't been very successful - at least, Glimmer hadn't been very optimistic about recruiting more sorceresses for police work instead of the Alliance forces.

But she had to focus on the task at hand now. She took a deep breath and nodded at Anise. "Thank you for coming, Anise and Freya."

"We're allies - and friends," Anise replied. "Of course, we'll come when you need us."

“And when you need us,” Adora heard Catra whisper under her breath.

She didn’t react, though. “Yes. Do you have more information about the state of Apophis’ court and forces?”

Anise nodded. “Our operatives have reported that he’s still conducting a purge of his court. He has culled at least a dozen Goa’uld and triple that number of Jaffa for treachery or incompetence - which he seems to use interchangeably.”

“Your god cannot fail. He can only be failed,” Jack commented.

“And failure is treachery,” Daniel added.

“Yes,” Teal’c said, nodding. “That is what the false gods teach their followers.”

“The loss of his queen has weakened his position. He has taken steps to hide that fact - he has killed the witnesses - but he cannot conceal it forever. Already rumours are spreading that she was hurt during the attack - or that she was behind it,” Anise went on.

Adora looked at Sha’re. The woman smiled at that, but she looked more resigned than satisfied. Of course, she would have known the other women in Apophis’s harem, who had been murdered just for seeing Amaunet being captured.

“That will greatly weaken his position,” Sha’re said. “Losing his queen is already a heavy blow, but rumours that she betrayed him? And reports of an attack on his palace, with significant damage? His rivals will probe for more weaknesses. And he will have purged some of his senior commanders and subordinates, in addition to those you killed, while his faith in the remaining ones will be shaken as well - and justly so. Most of the Goa’uld serving him will be looking for an opportunity to betray him, and the rest is only loyal out of fear.”

"Yes," Anise confirmed. "Our own assessment concurs. Even worse for Apophis, it seems his hold on his Jaffa is weakening as well."

"It is?" Teal'c leaned forward.

Anise nodded. "Our operatives confirmed that some of the surviving Jaffa who have fought you are questioning their god. In secret, of course."

"Do you know why they are doing this? As a rule, Jaffa have been fanatically loyal to their Goa'uld lords," Daniel said.

Anise lanced at Adora. "We are looking into it. We have heard that some of them talk - or whisper - about a 'golden goddess'."

Adora closed her eyes. Not again! "I am no goddess!" she muttered.

"Ah, yes," Daniel said. "Adora returning magic to the planet, and the effects of this action, especially her healing, would be able to shake even a Jaffa's faith. Though I would have expected Apophis to claim this, ah, deed, for his own."

"He tried, but too many Jaffa had witnessed the event, and killing them made even his followers question why he would heal them in the first place only to execute them afterwards." Anise shrugged. "It's too early to say how this will shake out, but it is another problem for Apophis to deal with when he's already dealing with multiple crises."

"That sounds like Apophis is a prime target for an attack," Jack said. "The only question is who will strike at him first - a rival snake or us."

"He still has a tight hold on his forces on other planets; rumours are spreading through his systems, but slowly. And hearsay will not impress people as much as personal experience or at least the testimony of first-hand witnesses," Anise pointed out.

“And we need to settle our problems with the Asgard before we can launch an attack on Apophis,” Adora added.

“Ah, yes,” Anise nodded. “We don’t know much about the Asgard - but the Goa’uld consider them a peer power, at the very least, and respect the treaty with them. Though last we heard, their goals aligned with ours. What happened to change that?”

“Our goals still align with regard to the Goa’uld Empire,” Adora said. “As far as we know.”

“We don’t know much about the Asgard either,” Glimmer added. “We only met two of them, but one of them is Thor, the Supreme Commander of the Asgard Fleet and member of their High Council. And he took offence at us helping Loki, who is trying to find a cure for their genetic degradation.”

Anise looked surprised. “They do not want your help?”

“They don’t trust Loki,” Adora explained.

“Apparently, he violated a lot of their laws in the past,” Jack said. “And they think we’re the same.”

“Ah.” Anise nodded. “I can see how that would be a problem.”

“Hindsight is always 20/20,” Jack said with a shrug.

There wasn’t much to add to that. They should have been honest from the start.

“So, what are you planning to do?” Anise asked.

“Talk to them and explain that we only want to help them,” Adora said.

“With the entire High Council, not just Thor,” Glimmer added.

“What if they do not believe you?” Anise leaned forward a little. “And what if they do not want your help? Or Loki’s?”

Andora grimaced. “That’s a tricky question. They can’t forbid Loki from working on this - well, they can, they did, but it’s not right. That would be like ordering him to commit suicide since if their genetic degradation continues, he won’t be able to get a new body and die.”

“And no kingdom has the right to order people to die,” Glimmer added.

“Well, there’s the death penalty,” Jack cut in. “And sometimes, you have to order soldiers to their deaths in a war.”

Adora frowned. The death penalty was barbaric. Brutal, cruel and such a waste. But Jack was correct about soldiers in a war - even though she’d do anything to avoid giving such orders, she would do it if there was no other way.

“And even without Loki’s past deeds, ah, mudding the water, it’s understandable that the Asgard would resent an outsider interfering with them on such a fundamental level,” Daniel said. “Loki *is* trying to define their future - without their approval.”

“If they want to die, then why should he listen to them?” Catra asked. “Once they’re gone, it doesn’t matter to them any more.”

“Well, their legacy obviously matters to them,” Daniel retorted. “They might consider this an appropriation or usurpation of their species’ identity, history and culture. Imagine if this happened to your kingdom.” He looked at Glimmer.

Glimmer frowned in return. “I wouldn’t want my kingdom to die rather than change.”

“Life means change,” Bow added. “Nothing can last without adapting and changing.”

“The Asgard tried, in a way at least,” Sam said. “They have been transferring their consciousnesses into new bodies.” She frowned.

Daniel nodded. “That would make it likely that their society is deeply conservative and inherently opposed to changes. Even at the cost of their own and their species’ existence.”

“It might be why they are facing extinction in the first place,” Sha’re spoke up. “On a fundamental level, they stopped changing, stopped adapting - stopped evolving.”

Adora nodded. That made sense. She noted that Sam seemed surprised by Sha’re’s words.

*****

Sha’re is more eloquent than I expected, Samantha Carter thought - and immediately felt ashamed for the assumption. Just because the other woman had been raised on Abydos didn’t mean that she would be… simple might be a good word. She had been married and living with Daniel since the first Stargate mission, after all, and Sam knew how prone to lecturing Daniel was. And then Sha’re had been possessed by Amaunet for years. Of course, she would have picked up more than just intel while she had been a prisoner in her own body. Sam knew from personal experience that if all you could do was observe, you did that - even though, sometimes, you’d rather not.

That didn’t mean she was right, of course. “That seems a bit philosophical,” Sam said.

Sha’re looked at her, but Daniel replied before she could: “It is - but that doesn’t mean we should dismiss the idea.”

“It’s not a philosophical point,” Sha’re said, frowning a little. “If you are no longer concerned with evolving, merely with maintaining the current state, you tend to grow lax as familiarity breeds contempt. Without a challenge, you don’t rise above your current level.”

“That sounds like a description of the Goa’uld,” the General cut in. “They’ve been keeping things the same for thousands of years.”

“Not quite,” Anise retorted. “While they might not have advanced their technology very much, which would support your assessment, their internal struggles did keep them from growing too complacent. One also has to consider that due to their inherent traitorous nature, any technological advantage gained by one System Lord tends to be quickly stolen and spread to their rivals. So, for extensive research and development to be profitable, a Goa’uld has to not only develop new technology - and advanced enough to render existing technology obsolete - but also build and deploy it in sufficient quantity to overpower their rivals without them noticing that buildup. Sufficient to not only topple the most powerful Goa’uld, namely Ra, but also defeat the coalition of their rivals that would form as soon as their power was revealed. This has been attempted multiple times in the past, with varying degrees of success, but never did it fundamentally change the balance of power under Ra - or Ra himself.”

“But Ra’s gone for a few years already,” the General said.

“And you can be assured that the System Lords have been busy trying to find a decisive advantage over their rivals ever since they didn’t have to fear Ra’s wrath any more,” Anise said. “We have been striking at the research projects that we found - such as that laboratory we sabotaged when we met you.”

“But there might be other such projects,” the General said. “Wunderwaffen.”

“Wunderwaffen?” Anise cocked her head to the side.

“A propaganda term from the Second World War on Earth,” Sam told her. “It referred to revolutionary weapons that were meant to change the outcome of the war, although they never were deployed in numbers high enough to actually have a significant effect on the war.”

“Ah.”

“So, let’s hope that whatever the snakes are working on in secret follows that example,” the General said.

“The sooner we strike at the Go’auld, the less time they have to develop new weapons,” Glimmer said.

“But as soon as we reveal ourselves, they will have a reason to band together against us,” Adora cautioned.

“What’s Apophis working on?” Anise asked, looking at Sha’re.

“He did not share all he was plotting with Amaunet,” she replied. “She was privy to some secret troop deployments but not to any such research projects. If she had been, she might have tried to gain control over it to topple him.”

“You’ve received that intel already,” the General told Anise with a slight frown.

Sam pressed her lips together at the implications as well. They wouldn’t hide that kind of information from their allies - especially not their allies with the best spy network in the Goa’uld Empire.

Anise nodded. “We digress. We were talking about the Asgard.”

“Right.” Adora nodded. “We’ll have to meet with them. Explain our point of view.”

“And without Loki there,” Catra added.

Sam agreed. Loki wouldn’t like that, but as the meeting with Tor had shown, if they wanted the High Council to listen to them, they couldn’t have Loki interfere. And his mere presence would escalate matters if Thor’s reaction was an example of the general view of the Asgard.

“Is this a meeting between the Alliance and the Asgard? Or Etheria and the Asgard?” Anise asked.

That was a good question. The agreement with Loki was, technically, between the Princess Alliance - or Bright Moon - and Loki, but SG-1 had been present as well, and it wasn't as if representatives of Earth had protested when they had been informed about it. However, they likely wouldn't have realised the consequences of the deal at the time. And while the Tok'ra, Earth and Etheria were in an Alliance against the Goa'uld, Sam doubted that the Asgard would draw that distinction. On the other hand, the Asgard might consider the Tok'ra just another faction of the Goa'uld.

"I think it would be best if you were present as well," Adora said, smiling. "So they won't feel that we're hiding something else."

"Well, we're not going to reveal our military secrets to them, I hope," the General commented in a joking tone that didn't quite hide his concern - at least to Sam.

"Of course not!" Adora said.

"But we would want some representatives of Earth with us as well, then," Daniel said. "I mean, representatives other than us. Elected ones."

"Of course," Glimmer said. Though the way she looked at Adora, Sam couldn't help thinking that they would much prefer to handle this with SG-1 and the Tok'ra.

"Great, more politicians," the General muttered.

"I was thinking more about diplomats," Daniel said.

"Same thing," the General retorted. "They'll mess this up."

"I wouldn't go that far," Daniel said.

"I would," the General insisted.

"I'm sure we can find a reasonable diplomat or two on Earth," Glimmer said.

Catra scoffed. “You remember our tour of the United Nations, do you?”

“That was the United Nations. We’re talking about the Alliance countries,” Glimmer replied. But she did look a little unsure, in Sam’s opinion.

“They will send a delegation, I think,” Daniel said. “So every major member of the Alliance is represented.”

“So… at least four? With assistants?” Glimmer shook her head. “That won’t work.”

“Well…” Daniel shrugged. “Etheria’s represented by all of you.” He nodded at Adora, Glimmer, and the others.

Glimmer had the grace to blush, Sam noted. But she shook her head anyway. “Technically, it’s just me for Bright Moon and Adora for the Alliance as a whole.”

“Ad me as a science expert,” Entrapta said with a smile.

“Then the countries of Earth could claim the same,” Daniel said.

“We’ll ask them to send a delegation,” Adora said. “It’s only fair.”

“Great,” the General muttered.

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The Asgard Question Part 4

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, November 25th, 1999

Catra wasn't impressed by the Alliance delegation from Earth - the official Alliance delegation, at least. Four diplomats, one each from the United States, the United Kingdom, France and Germany, with their assistants. At least they didn't have guards with them - it was already a huge delegation. "A few more, and we would outnumber the Princess Alliance meetings," she muttered as she leaned against the railing leading to the Stargate.

Glimmer, on her left, snorted at that. Adora, on Catra's right, didn't.

"Maybe we could lose them on the way? Have the gate malfunction and send them somewhere else?" Catra suggested.

Glimmer chuckled, and Adora finally reacted: "Catra!"

"I think that would be possible," Entrapta said. "We would have to shut the gate down and then dial to another address. But I don't think we could do that accidentally."

"Catra was joking," Adora told her.

"Ah."

"It's still too many people in the delegation," Glimmer said. "At least they agreed that they couldn't all have a say in the actual talks. But they'll badger us between the meetings."

"And some of them will want to speak up anyway, I bet," Catra said. The US Secretary of State, for one - the man didn't strike her as being content to observe in silence. And if he spoke, the other three diplomats would want to speak as well. They could only hope that the man's assistant would be able to control him - but the woman was an unknown; at least the Princess Alliance had no

records of a Dr Weir talking with them, and she hadn't been part of Stargate Command either.

"Well, yes. For all their talk about democracies being different from kingdoms, their leaders have the same egos as princesses," Glimmer said.

"You would know." Catra grinned when Glimmer frowned at her.

"Catra!" Adora hissed again. "They're coming over!"

"About time."

But Catra straightened when the Earth delegation approached them. No need to antagonise them from the start. She could wait until they gave her a reason.

Besides, Jack probably had annoyed them already - at least judging by the way he was trying not to grin, and half the diplomats tried not to show their annoyance. Weir, though, looked perfectly composed, Catra noted as everyone greeted each other.

"Alright. Since everyone's here, we can dial to the temporary base," Adora said.

"From which we will travel to the Asgard planet, right?" the Secretary of State asked.

"Yes, once the Tok'ra delegation has joined us," Glimmer told him. "As you were told at the briefing. And it's not actually an Asgard planet - it's a planet under their control, but nominally free."

"Yes, a Viking planet." The man nodded.

"Actually, it's Norse. They don't call themselves Vikings," Daniel added. "That was a term that originally just described a sea journey - at least according to the latest theory. Unfortunately, unless and until we resolve the current tension with the Asgard, we can't contact the Cimmerians to learn more about this. It's a fascinating opportunity to find out more about our own past."

Most of the diplomats smiled politely at that, Catra noted. They probably didn't like the fact that Daniel would be talking directly to the Asgard. Well, sucked to be them. She trusted Daniel a lot more than she trusted any of them.

"We should have taken a ship there," the American Secretary of State commented. "Show the flag."

"That would take too long. And they might not want to let us visit one of their planets with a spaceship," Jack said.

"And we might not want to show our ships to them at this point," the British diplomat added. "Just in case the negotiations fall through."

"That's why we're not bringing all of our bots with us," Entrapta said. "But we'll take Emily with us - they already saw her. But don't worry; she can keep all of us safe!"

"That didn't seem to reassure the delegation as much as Entrapta thought it would, Catra noticed.

Well, that's not my problem, Catra thought as the Stargate began to dial.

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Gate Area, Cimmeria, November 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"As often as we visit here, we might as well ask for an embassy," Jack O'Neill commented as he walked down the Stargate's ramp. "Would save us some trips."

"Shouldn't we wait with such plans until we have straightened things with the Asgard?" Daniel asked as he joined Jack. "I don't think they would want us on one of their protected planets if they think we're trying to subvert their species. Of course, even if we manage to smooth out our relations, they might be concerned about our effect on the Cimmerians - our mere presence would affect them unless we completely isolate ourselves, and I think

that wouldn't be realistic. The Asgard would have concerns about our influence here - not unreasonable ones, actually, given our history."

Jack snorted. "I was joking, Daniel."

"Ah." Daniel pouted a little - his friend tended to take Jack a bit too seriously - but when Sha're leaned into his side and whispered something into his ear, he quickly brightened.

Jack didn't make a comment about young love or anything. The couple had gone through too much for that to joke about it. And it would make him sound a bit jealous. Not that he was jealous, of course - he was perfectly happy with his current life. Mostly.

"The Asgard's sensors do not seem to have been upgraded since our last visit, sir," Carter reported.

He nodded. He had expected that - it hadn't been too long, after all. It was still a good sign, though. If the Asgard had upgraded the defences here, despite their war against those killer robots, then that would have meant they were pretty concerned about the Alliance. Or about the Goa'uld. Either possibility would have been bad.

"There's a ship in orbit," Entrapta said. She was looking at the sky, her visor down and slightly glowing.

"Can you spot it from here?" Jack asked.

"Yes. But Emily detected it first and then fed me her sensor data so I knew where to look. I could have spotted it without Emily's help, but it would have taken me longer. And my visor's software isn't as good at getting target data at that range as Emily's - it's mostly optimised for short-range analysis. And, of course, eye protection!"

The bot bringing up the rear of their delegation - which was too big for Jack's taste - beeped.

He nodded. He wasn't happy with revealing such information where they knew the Asgard were listening, but Adora wanted to be as honest as possible to rebuild trust. Jack doubted it would work - Thor probably thought that was an act or misinformation.

Well, Jack could live with that. He glanced at their guests.

The diplomats looked around like tourists, not quite gaping but clearly out of their element. The Secretary of State was bending over to look at a patch of grass. "This looks exactly like grass back home," he commented.

"That is grass from Earth, sir," Carter told him. "Genetic analysis showed that it was taken from Earth - Scandinavia, actually - at roughly the same time as the Cimmerians were moved here. If it had been introduced by the Ancients when they built the Stargate, the genetic drift would have been more significant. It was in the briefing."

The man straightened and frowned at her. Probably annoyed at the implication that he hadn't read through all the files provided to them. Well, Jack hadn't read them in-depth either. He trusted Carter to tell him about stuff like that if it became important.

"It's a reminder that the Goa'uld were not the only ones to operate on Earth in the past," Weir said. "Both them and the Asgard took humans from their homes and settled them on alien planets."

Jack grinned. That was a nice dig at the Asgard. They might complain about Loki's plans, but they didn't have a lily-white vest either when it came to manipulating another species. Weir was sneakier than he had first thought - then again, the US government wouldn't send dull people on this mission. "Well, everybody's here! So…" He cleared his throat. "Earth to Asgard, anyone home?"

"You're early."

That sounded like Thor. Quite a bit ruder than last time, too.

“Hi, Thor! Better early than late. If you’re not ready, we can wait.” Jack shrugged. “I brought my Game Boy.”

The Secretary of State coughed at that, but Jack ignored him as he ignored the snorts and chuckles from his friends.

“That will not be necessary. We require that you allow us to scan you for prohibited and dangerous items.”

“We’re here to talk to you, not to fight you,” Adora said, frowning. “But didn’t you scan us as soon as we arrived?”

That was how their anti-snake defence system worked, after all.

“Prepare to be scanned.” Apparently, Thor ignored the comment.

Jack looked around, but the gate area hadn’t changed. Anise was tense, as expected - they had informed Thor that a Tok’ra would be coming along and had had assurances that she wouldn’t be treated as a Goa’uld, but… you could never be sure, could you?

“Oh, the ship’s using her scanners!” Entrapta piped up. “Quite powerful ones!”

But were they working at full power? Probably not. They would also be scanned once they arrived at the actual meeting location, before meeting the High Council.

“The machine has to stay behind,”

“Her name is Emily!” Entrapta protested. “And why? She hasn’t done anything wrong.”

“Her weapon systems make her too dangerous for the meeting.”

Jack wondered what Thor would say if he knew how dangerous She-Ra was.

“Emily will guard the gate here,” Adora said.

“It’s still unfair!” Entrapta pouted. The bot beeped, and she turned to look at it. “You haven’t done anything wrong! You aren't able to replicate yourself, so there's no reason to be afraid of you!”

“But we’re visiting the Asgard. Their home, their rules,” Weir said.

For an assistant, the woman wasn’t afraid to speak up. But the rest of the diplomats took that as a sign that they, too, had to comment.

“We can’t let this delegation fail merely over a bot,” the Secretary of State said.

“And diplomatic meetings are generally conducted without heavy weapons,” the German envoy added.

“Generally not, no,” the Brit agreed.

“On the other hand, it’s also generally understood and accepted that we bring our own security,” the French diplomat pointed out.

“We’ll leave Emily here,” Adora repeated herself.

Entrapta wasn’t happy but nodded. Hordak put a hand on her shoulder, and she relaxed a little, Adora saw.

“Good. Stand by for the gate address,” Thor announced.

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Gate Area, Undesignated Asgard World, November 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

This isn’t an actual Asgard world, Adora thought as she stepped down the gate ramp. The Stargate was out in the open, not in a building. However, there were defence systems similar to those on Cimmeria - more extensive, though, and not concealed. And two pillars flanked the gate itself - was that an Asgard version of an iris? If they didn’t want Emily to come along, they wouldn’t risk someone invading the place, either, would they?

As the others arrived behind her, she studied the building ahead of them. It didn't look particularly temporary. Quite sturdy, full stone, but also quite bare. And…

"No trails around the building," Catra commented. "No streets. No landing pads. No sign that anyone used this before."

Exactly. Adora nodded. Of course, with their transporter technology, the Asgard wouldn't need landing pads.

And there was nothing else around them - just an empty plain. Sure, most worlds seemed to avoid settling the area right next to the Stargate - probably to avoid any trouble coming through it - but there usually would be some traces of traffic. In short, as expected, this looked like an empty world that the Asgard had picked for the meeting.

"Any bet how long they'll make us wait?" Jack asked as he joined them.

"Jack! We can't expect an alien culture to have the same customs as Earth - or Etheria," Daniel said. "Rushing a meeting could be a sign of disrespect for the Asgard."

Catra snorted at that. "It would fit Loki's manners," she said. "The way he's always trying to rush things. And he's certainly rude when he thinks he can get away with it."

"Well, you're an expert on rudeness," Glimmer said.

Adora clenched her teeth - this wasn't the time to bicker! - but Catra snorted in return.

"Letting your guests wait at the gate is generally considered rude," Sha're commented. "At least amongst the Goa'uld."

"And the Tok'ra," Anise added.

"We were conducting further scans," a voice sounded from one of the pillars. *"Given whom you associate with, it was deemed*

appropriate to take a cautious approach."

"You could have just talked to us over comms if you're afraid we'll attack you," Entrapta commented. It seemed she was still annoyed at Emily's treatment.

"That would have been rude."

Jack snorted at that. "Well, they haven't lost their humour."

Adora hoped so. They really needed to reach an understanding with the Asgard.

Before anyone else could say anything, the door in the building ahead of them opened, and an Asgard appeared. Thor - or someone who looked more like Thor than Loki. It was a bit hard to tell them apart without closer observation. Or when they weren't together.

"The Asgard High Council welcomes you and bids you to enter." The voice sounded like Thor's.

"Great!" Adora smiled at him.

They entered the building, which was basically one big room with two long tables facing each other and a big screen on the wall. There were two more Asgard sitting behind the table facing the door.

Thor nodded to them. "These are Freyr and Penegal, members of the Asgard High Council."

Adora smiled at them and introduced herself and the others. Though she couldn't help feeling a bit awkward - they outnumbered the Asgard delegation by so many! Maybe they should have limited their numbers…

"Please have a seat," Thor said as he sat down. "We represent the High Council."

As they took their seats, Adora wondered if the rest of the High Council was watching through cameras or if they were trusting the entire meeting to those three. It didn't matter - they were here, and they could finally sort this out.

"Thank you for receiving us," she said, standing up and nodding at them once everyone was seated. "We're here to discuss the situation with Loki and, so we hope, straighten things out between the Asgard and the Alliance. We do not wish any harm on you."

"And yet, you not only shelter a criminal but give him support so he can continue to break our laws," Thor said.

That wasn't a good start. "He asked for help with the genetic degradation you suffer from," Adora said. "Why wouldn't we help him if we can?"

"Because he is a criminal," Thor said.

Freyr raised his hand. "Did you verify his claims?"

Adora nodded. "We did confirm the genetic degradation." Once Loki had arrived on the Third Moon of Enchantment, at least.

"And that was enough for you to trust him?" Penegal asked.

"Yes." Adora nodded again. "Enough to help him."

The Asgard exchanged glances.

"We have him under close observation," Glimmer added. "We're aware of the risks of such experiments."

"Risks such as the creation of Horde Prime," Thor said. He and the others looked at Hordak.

"Yes."

"And yet, you did not contact us." Freyr inclined his head.

"No, we didn't," Adora admitted. Perhaps they should have. But that would have felt like betraying Loki's confidence.

"Why not?" Penegal leaned forward. "Were you aware that he was a wanted criminal?"

Adora raised her chin. "We assumed that. But he asked for help, and we think everyone deserves a chance to change."

"Everyone?" Freyr tilted his head to the side.

"Everyone." Adora nodded firmly.

"Even the Goa'uld?"

"Even them, yes." Adora didn't flinch.

"And yet, according to your claims, you destroyed Horde Prime," Thor cut in.

"We gave him a chance as well," Adora told him.

"And he forced our hand," Glimmer added.

The Asgard exchanged glances again. Adora wished she could read them better.

Freyr turned back to her. "Putting this policy of yours aside for the moment, sheltering a wanted criminal does not seem to be a friendly act. Doubly so if you help him to commit the same actions that made him a wanted criminal in the first place."

That was… Well, it made sense when seen like that from the Asgard's point of view. But it was still wrong!

Daniel spoke up. "I think that depends on what exactly those actions you condemn Loki for are. We haven't been informed about his crimes yet."

Except for the faked Replicator outbreak that Loki had been planning, Adora thought with a pang of guilt.

“You are aware that he created Horde Prime,” Thor said. “His reckless, illegal experiments endangered everyone - the Asgard and the entire sector. Dozens of sapient species were rendered extinct as a result of Loki breaking our laws. What more do you need to condemn his actions?”

“But Loki didn’t intend to do that!” Entrapta blurted out. “He just made a mistake while experimenting, and his lab security procedures were insufficient!”

“That’s why he was banned from such experiments,” Thor replied. “Because he had already proven before that debacle that he cannot be trusted to take the necessary safety and security precautions.”

“But now we are taking those precautions,” Entrapta retorted. “So, it’s not the same.”

“Indeed,” Hordak chimed in. “Loki is under strict supervision, and thorough safety standards are enforced. There will be no repeat of Horde Prime’s creation.”

The Asgard looked at him, but not for long. The Asgard hadn’t really said anything about the Clones since the meeting started, Adora realised. And since the Clones were, technically, descendants of Loki and so closely related to the Asgard that their own systems had been fooled once, that was a little weird.

More than a little, actually.

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The Clones were a sore spot for the Asgard. Samantha Carter had suspected it before, but she was now quite sure. The way they avoided looking at Hordak, the way they had skipped the Clones’ creation entirely when focusing on Horde Prime’s creation, even though, at least from a purely technical point of view, the Clones also were the result of Loki’s attempts to solve their genetic degradation problem… It looked like this was something they didn’t want to address. Or face.

“So you claim,” Thor shot back.

“You have visited the research station,” Sam pointed out. “You’ve seen the measures we take to ensure there will not be another mishap.” Although, unless Thor was a scientist as well as a fleet commander, he might not have sufficient skill to judge the effectiveness of the lab’s security procedures.

“It is a research base of the Gate Builders - the Ancients or First Ones, as you call them. Their security procedures have not always been up to the challenge that their experiments presented, to say the least,” Penegal retorted.

“Feel free to inspect them yourself if you don’t trust us,” Glimmer cut in with a scowl.

Daniel leaned forward, smiling widely - though a little forcedly, Sam could tell. “And if you feel that the security precautions are insufficient, any suggestions to improve them are welcome. We understand your concerns.”

Adora nodded. “We have faced Horde Prime, after all. We have seen what he did and the results of his actions. We don’t take this lightly.”

“And we aren’t Loki,” Hordak added.

Once more, the Asgard glanced at him, acknowledging his point without addressing him.

“That is a generous offer,” Freyr said. “Although you did not offer to stop his experiments.”

“Why would we?” Entrapta asked. “You’re in danger of dying out due to your genetic problems, and Loki’s trying to fix that. Why should we stop that? We want to help you!”

“Because this is a matter of the Asgard,” Freyr replied. “You are outsiders. It is none of your business.”

“But Loki is an Asgard as well,” Daniel pointed out.

“One who is breaking our laws by these experiments,” Thor said. “With your help.”

“Your laws do not apply to our worlds,” Glimmer retorted. “We’re not your subjects.”

“This is true,” Freyr said, nodding. “But this is not a mere legal matter. By supporting him and his experiments, even if, as you claim, you have taken sufficient measures to render them safe, you are directly intervening in an Asgard matter against the will of the High Council. This is a direct attack on our sovereignty.”

Glimmer frowned at that, Sam noticed.

“But we’re trying to help you!” Entrapta repeated herself before anyone else could reply.

“We don’t want your help!” Thor snapped. “Nor Loki’s. Especially not Loki’s.”

Entrapta’s eyes widened. “But why? You do need help!”

Sam winced. Her friend meant well - and was probably correct - but this wasn’t very diplomatic.

“At least, that is our impression,” Daniel added. He pushed his glasses up as he looked at the Asgard.

Thor scowled at the implied question. “Our researchers are working on a cure.”

“Oh! Can we share data? If we combine our data, we might be able to find a solution together!” Entrapta beamed.

After a glance at Thor and Penegal, Freyr shook his head. “Our efforts are aimed at another solution than Loki’s plans.”

Sam nodded. “You’re working on stopping the degradation. Loki is working on creating a new body.” And if they hadn’t managed to find a solution yet, it didn’t look as if they would succeed in the future.

“A new species,” Penegal said with another glance at Hordak. “As he has done before. We wouldn’t be Asgard anymore if he succeeded.”

“That’s debatable,” Daniel spoke up again. “What defines you? Your appearance? Your genes? Your history? Your culture? Your values? All of that changes over time. You know that already, thanks to your long history and records.”

“It has to,” Sha’re added. “To live is to change.”

That triggered another round of scowls amongst the Asgard, Sam noted.

*****

Catra caught herself before she nodded in agreement with Sha’re, but the woman was correct. If Catra hadn’t changed, she doubted she would be alive any more. Or if she were, would want to be. Adapt or die was the rule in war as well. Though, sometimes, you could change for the worse - as Catra had proved in the Horde War.

“It is a matter of degrees,” Freyr said after a moment. “Loki’s plans are too drastic. They wouldn’t make us Asgard anymore. Like the Clones.”

He didn’t nod at Hordak, Catra noted.

Hordak didn’t react to the declaration. Cata had half-expected him to say that the Clones didn’t want to be Asgard anyway. Although… was that actually true? She didn’t know. The Clones had broken with Horde Prime, arguably their parent, even if he called them brothers, and Loki, who could be considered the Clones’ grandparent, genetically at least, hadn’t endeared himself

to anyone - least of all the Clones; he hadn't really hidden that he lumped them in with Horde Prime.

But would that attitude towards Horde Prime and Loki extend to the rest of the Asgard?

"You can't just deny that your children are your children! That's not how genetics work!" Entrapta, who had been gaping at the Asgard, blurted out.

"The mere fact that Asgard DNA was used in the creation of a life form doesn't make the result an Asgard," Freyr retorted. "Not even if the result is a sapient life form. To be an Asgard means more than mere genetics."

Daniel cocked his head to the side. "But what does it mean, being Asgard? You haven't answered that. And I think that's an important question for this discussion."

"To be an Asgard, you not only have to share our genome but also our culture and values," Thor stated.

"Now, where did I hear that before?" Catra heard Jack mutter.

"Oh, like the Tok'ra and the Go'auld?" Entrapta turned to Anise. "You are biologically the same, well, except for your genetic memory, which is different, but that's different amongst individuals anyway - but you don't consider each other a member of the same species."

Anise frowned but nodded. "Yes. To be Tok'ra is not a matter of mere biology."

"Ah."

The Asgard didn't show any reaction to the comparison. At least not one Catra could spot.

Daniel pushed his glasses up. "Does that mean Loki isn't an Asgard any more? You claim that he doesn't share your values."

Freyr inclined his head. “That has been debated by the High Council.”

“But you haven’t ruled that he isn’t an Asgard any more,” Daniel said, nodding. “Does that mean there were such cases in the past?”

Penegal tensed at that, Catra noted, and Thor and Freyr glanced at each other before the former said: “That is not germane to this discussion.”

Which meant ‘yes’ in Catra’s book. Interesting. As interesting as the fact that they hadn’t expelled Loki from their species.

Daniel nodded. “So, Loki’s actions so far were not enough to, ah, remove his Asgard citizenship…”

“His Asgard Club membership,” Jack cut in with a grin.

“...but you don’t consider the Clones Asgard. Is that based on their genetic makeup? If they shared your culture, would you consider them Asgard?” Daniel asked with a side glance at Jack.

“The question is moot since they don’t share our culture, values and heritage,” Freyr said.

“We don’t know your culture, values and heritage,” Hordak said. “Do you know ours?”

“We know Horde Prime didn’t share our culture and values,” Penegal replied. “And we haven’t shared them with you.”

“Loki might have,” Catra said. When everyone stared at her, she shrugged. “He hasn’t, but what if he decides to do that with his next children?”

“Loki is not a representative of the Asgard,” Thor snapped.

“Yet you have not purged him from the Asgard,” Daniel pointed out.

“He is a criminal. Would you want your criminals to shape your children?” Freyr asked.

Literally, in this case, Catra thought with a soft snort.

“What if you could shape his children?” Daniel asked.

“What do you mean?” Freyr asked.

Daniel smiled. “You don’t want Loki to claim Asgard’s future. You claim he doesn’t respect your culture and values. What if you could instil your values in his, ah, children? By raising them?”

“As long as you haven’t forgotten how to raise children,” Jack said in a low voice, followed by Sam’s hissed “Sir!”.

He was right, but in Catra’s opinion, pretty much anyone would probably be a better parent than Loki. Well, with the exception of Horde Prime or Shadow Weaver, of course.

The Asgard were looking at each other again. They seemed to be surprised. At least, that was Catra’s impression. Hadn’t they thought of that? To be fair, she hadn’t thought of that either.

“The question of their genetic makeup remains,” Freyr said.

“And Loki plans for them to reproduce sexually,” Thor added.

“As an option,” Sam retorted. “The Asgard did so in the past, didn’t they?”

“In the distant past,” Penegal said. He didn’t quite shudder, but his tone hinted at it.

But they didn’t seem to reject Daniel’s idea straight away. That was a good sign.

Probably.

Of course, whether Loki would agree with this proposal was up in the air. Shadow Weaver would never have agreed to relinquish

control like that. And Catra didn't think Loki was too different.

*****

Well, Daniel is delivering, Jack O'Neill thought. He got the Asgard thinking about his idea, at least. And that was no mean feat with aliens that made even the Amish look like rabid progressives or something. No, that is unfair to the Amish, he corrected himself. Amish teenagers looked at new things and even experienced them before they returned to their permanent Renaissance Fair-lifestyle. The Asgard, though, seemed stuck in their ways. Superglued and welded to them. And digging in their heels at the hint of the slightest change.

At least, that was his impression. Of course, they had only met four Asgard so far - three members of their government and one renegade - so Jack might be completely wrong about the average Asgard. He didn't think he was, though.

"So, will you entertain the proposal?" Daniel was beaming at the Asgard.

"We will have to discuss this with the High Council," Freyr said.

Jack was reminded of the tone parents used when they didn't want to tell their kids 'no' straight away. He had used it himself, back when… And he shut that line of thought down before it grew painful.

"Of course." Daniel nodded, still smiling.

"Do you need more data? We have the latest data and projections!" Entrapta piped up. She, too, was beaming.

Jack suppressed a sigh. They were too optimistic. Idealistic. Hordak, at least, looked as grouchy as ever. And Sha're seemed to be more pessimistic as well - her smile looked more bland. Polite, rather than heartfelt. Like the diplomats'.

Jack glanced at them. So far, they had been surprisingly silent. He had expected them to try and take over the negotiations, or at least say something just to feel important. But either they knew enough not to break the Alliance's united front in public, or they had been instructed not to make the Etherians mad.

Or, he added when he looked at Weir in particular, who was studying the Asgard with the same expression Entrapta looked at anything dangerous, they were here to gather information for their governments.

Probably a mix of both.

"No, thank you."

Entrapta frowned. "But how can you make an informed decision if you don't have all the data you need?"

"This is a matter of principle," Thor told her. "And, as such, it should not be influenced by details."

Now, that was a weird way to look at things.

"Are you sure?" Daniel asked. "You said this was a crucial matter for your people. Shouldn't you know what you are refusing or accepting?"

Freyr glanced at Hordak before answering: "Before we decide whether or not we would consider the… results of Loki's experiments as potential Asgards, we have to decide if we are open to the basic idea of incorporating new members in the first place."

Jack frowned. That sounded like…

"Does that mean you have stopped reproducing at all?" Carter asked. "Even asexually?"

Once again, the Asgard hesitated, which was answer enough in Jack's book.

“So, you have to decide whether you want to survive in the first place?” Entrapta blinked. “Because if you don’t reproduce any more, even if you fix your genetic problems and continue to clone your bodies, you will die out in the long term just from accidents alone. Though, depending on how cautious you are, it might take a long, long time.”

The Asgard were fighting a war - a war that, while being won, was fought hard, as far as Jack knew. And people died in war. So, it didn’t seem like the Asgard were being as cautious as they could be.

“As we said before, the fate of the Asgard will be decided by the Asgard. Not by anyone else,” Thor said.

“But…”

Entrapta was interrupted by Hordak putting his hand on her shoulder. “If they chose to die out, then that is their decision,” he said.

All three Asgard seemed surprised by that. Freyr nodded slowly at the clone with what seemed like his first genuine smile.

“But what if some of you dissent?” Glimmer asked. “Will you split then?”

“That is also a decision that will be made by the Asgard and no one else,” Freyr said. “Not by outsiders and not by renegades.”

And we’re back to square one, Jack thought. The Asgard hadn’t come out and said that they would force Loki into a collective suicide - if you could call stopping reproduction and waiting for their genes to fail that - but they also hadn’t said they wouldn’t do it.

On the other hand, at least they hadn’t threatened the Alliance with war so far. They hadn’t threatened them at all, actually, he realised - and if Loki’s experiments were as important for them as

they claimed, Jack would have expected some rumbling along those lines.

But did the lack of such sabre rattling mean that the Asgard weren't considering it, or did it mean that they couldn't afford it at this stage of their war with the robots and didn't want to bluff and risk Loki calling them out - or the Alliance calling their bluff?

They had a lot to discuss in the upcoming break.

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Temporary Base, Gate Area, PZ-1875, November 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Taking a break from negotiations on another planet is something new, I'll say," the British diplomat said as they stepped down the gate ramp inside their temporary base. "To think we were complaining about long distances at the United Nations in New York!"

Everyone chuckled at that. Adora did so as well - though mostly because she realised that this had become normal for her. If you could travel to another planet more easily and faster than to another city, why not do it?

"It also improves security," the American Secretary of State commented. "We won't have to worry about bugs in our quarters here."

That meant he didn't trust the Asgard not to install listening devices in whatever quarters they might provide for their guests. That was… Well, Adora liked to think the best of potential allies, but she couldn't say it was wrong to be cautious. She glanced at Catra as they approached the quarters that had been prepared in the base for them. Her lover would eavesdrop on others in a heartbeat if she thought it was justified. Or if they weren't careful enough and underestimated how good her ears were.

“Welcome to Forward Base 1875, Ma’am.” The officer in charge of the guards saluted her.

Adora returned the salute. “Anything to report?”

“No, Ma’am. Your quarters have been prepared as ordered.”

“Hope they didn’t forget the fish snacks this time!” Catra commented behind Adora.

The officer didn’t react, so either they had prepared Catra’s favourite snacks or thought she was joking.

They had prepared the snacks, Adora discovered a moment later when Catra made a beeline to the small buffet waiting for them inside.

“It feels a bit of a waste to erect a temporary base for a single diplomatic mission,” the German diplomat, Häckler, commented as the group spread out a bit and sat down at the table in the centre, with a few headed to the bathrooms in the back.

“It’s safer this way, sir,” Sam told him. “The Asgard know of this world because we travelled here from their meeting place, so if we had a permanent base here, it would be compromised.”

“Yes,” Glimmer chimed in. “Besides, it’s not much of a waste - and good training for the troops who will be setting up such bases during the offensive.”

“It’s a bit like the Roman Legions,” the Secretary of State commented. “They erected a fortified camp every evening on the march.”

That had been two thousand years ago, Adora thought while Daniel told them a bit more about this, correcting the diplomat’s general statement. It was weird how some things never changed.

“Anyway,” Glimmer spoke up again when everyone had grabbed a drink and some snacks. “What are your impressions of the

Asgard?”

“They’re very conservative,” the American Secretary of State said. “It seems they don’t want to change, not even if it costs them their lives.”

Some nodded in agreement, though not all.

“And their decision-making procedures are suspect,” Entrapta complained. “They didn’t want more data.”

“I think they don’t trust us,” Sam commented. “Because the data comes from Loki.”

“He probably sold them a load of goods before,” Jack said, nodding. “Promised them the sky and delivered a turd. A bit like it usually goes with new weapons,” he added with a grin.

“They do seem very wary,” Daniel agreed. “Unwilling to extend us much, if any, trust.”

The American assistant cleared her throat. “Or this could be motivated by internal politics,” Weir pointed out. “The High Council might be facing internal opposition who would use such information to push for a change of policy that the High Council doesn’t want.”

Daniel tilted his head. “We don’t know much about their political structure, but according to Loki’s information, the High Council is composed of the Asgard with the highest ranks and status - an oligarchy of sorts, possibly meant to be a Council of the Wise.”

“They don’t look like elves,” The British diplomat commented with a smile.

“A reference to Tolkien’s works,” Daniel explained.

“Ah.” Adora nodded, even though it didn’t tell her much.

“We don’t know if they are facing a popular movement,” Daniel went on. “They do seem a very conservative species - understandable, of course, since all of them live for thousands of years.”

“They could also have dissenters within the High Council,” Weir retorted. “The information Loki provided was a little scant on the makeup of the council.”

And quite biased, in Adora’s opinion.

“It’s all conjecture, though,” Häckler said. “We don’t know enough to tell. This complicates the negotiations.”

“They haven’t been very aggressive, though,” Weir said. “They seemed to argue more on moral grounds. They didn’t raise potential diplomatic or even military consequences. Though that could be based on their experiences with the Alliance representatives.”

Adora blinked. What did the woman mean?

“You think they know that we react better to such arguments than we would to threats?” Jack asked with a glance at Adora.

“They are a very old species, and we know they have a treaty with the Goa’uld, so they aren’t unused to diplomacy. I think it would be prudent not to underestimate them,” Weir said. “They might know more about us than we think - either through deductions from their interactions with us or through other means.”

That was a good point, Adora had to admit. She had thought the Asgard didn’t trust them because they didn’t know them, but if they thought they knew more about the Alliance…

Anise nodded. “They are an old species, and they have met many other species. If they were inexperienced at diplomacy, they would not have maintained their position as a power the Goa’uld do not want to provoke - they would have appeared weak and

easily fooled and been considered a source of more advanced technology instead."

"Some of the System Lords might see them as that," Sha're said. "Though they might not have taken actual steps to acquire Asgard technology, many would attempt it if they thought there was an opportunity to do so."

"But as far as you know, they haven't done so despite having met the Asgard thousands of years ago?" Weir asked.

"Not according to Apophis," Sha're replied.

"So, Thor's sneakier than he appeared." Glimmer shrugged. "It doesn't change much. We are here to show them we're not a threat to them."

"But we are a threat to them - at least to some of them," Daniel objected. "We challenge their entire society. Well, Loki does, but we're helping him."

Adora pressed her lips together. This was so frustrating - they just wanted to help the Asgard! "We have to clear this up," she said. They were making plans based on speculation, and that wasn't a good thing.

Honesty was the best policy.

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The Asgard Question Part 5

Temporary Base, Gate Area, PZ-1875, November 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"If we're exploring options," the Secretary of State spoke up just as Samantha Carter wondered if she could focus on a few calculations on her laptop instead of the talk about diplomacy, "then maybe we should ask why you want to help them."

Sam winced at that.

"What do you mean?" Adora asked. "They need help!"

"But they don't want help," the man went on. "They made that clear. The easiest way to settle things with them would be to honour their wishes."

"That would break our agreement with Loki," Glimmer replied.

The Secretary of State didn't say 'Yes, and?', but his polite expression wasn't quite enough to hide his thoughts.

"It would break our word," Adora added with a frown. "Who would trust us if we would go back on an agreement because someone else demanded it?"

"Unless the other side broke the agreement already," Catra added with a snort.

"Or the deal was made under false pretences?" Dr Weir asked, tilting her head a little.

"Yes," Glimmer said. "Though Loki didn't do that. We knew he wasn't supported by the rulers of Asgard."

"You didn't know what he had done in the past, though," Dr Weir pointed out.

“We still don’t know what he did,” Glimmer said. “The Asgard didn’t want to tell us.”

“They might be a very secretive species. Loki didn’t share much about his culture and history,” Daniel speculated. “Or they might be ashamed of their past - both the High Council and Loki, I mean. Bringing up shameful deeds from the past might be taboo in Asgard society.”

“Or they simply don’t want to risk information that could hurt them get out,” Sha’re said. “They know the Goa’uld, and so they know that any information showing a weakness of theirs would be exploited against them.”

“We aren’t the Goa’uld,” Entrapta protested.

“But they don’t know us - and they don’t trust us, as they clearly demonstrated today,” Daniel said.

“That’s why we need to show them we are trustworthy.” Adora nodded. “Once they know us, they will know they can trust us.”

“And that’s why breaking our word to Loki could backfire,” Glimmer added. “You don’t trust people who break their word.”

Catra mumbled something that Sam couldn’t make out. It made Adora frown at her, though, and say: “That’s not applicable here.”

“But if the choice came down between honouring your agreement with Loki and peace with the Asgard…” The Secretary of State began.

“We aren’t at war with the Asgard,” Adora interrupted him. “We’re talking with the Asgard to settle our differences and clear up misunderstandings so we both understand each other.”

“They haven’t even threatened to war over this,” the General added. “Of course, they’re already fighting a war of their own.”

“Yes. They would be foolish to engage in another war,” Sha’re agreed. “And as far as we know, the war against the Replicators won’t finish soon.”

“According to Loki. He’s not exactly privy to their strategic situation,” the General pointed out, “being a wanted criminal, and all.”

“We lack confirmed data about the war against the Replicators,” Entrapta said.

“If we send spy bots to the front, the Asgard might see that as a threat,” Bow cautioned.

Sam didn’t think it was very likely - but they didn’t know enough about the Asgard to tell. “And we would have to find the system they are fighting in first.”

“Good point. If the spy bot network were spreading exponentially, we would have a good chance of stumbling upon it,” Entrapta said. “But that would probably make the Asgard think we’re a threat.”

“Probably, yes.” The General’s sarcasm was obvious to everyone except Entrapta, who nodded with a smile.

“Exactly!”

Sam made a mental note to have a talk with him about it - he looked a little guilty already.

“Anyway, we’re not going to break our deal with Loki,” Glimmer said. “Because even if the Asgard decide to die out, he disagrees - and they don’t have the right to force him to join them.”

“Not the moral right, at least.” Daniel nodded. “They might have the formal right according to their laws and customs.”

“They said he broke their laws with his experiments,” the British envoy said. “But we have no treaty with them that would

recognise their laws."

"And we won't as long as they act like that." Adora shook her head.

"We would have to know their laws first anyway, before making a treaty," Glimmer added.

"Yeah, it wouldn't be a good idea to make a deal without knowing more about the other side," the General said with an innocent expression.

The Etherians frowned at him. "We knew enough to make the agreement with Loki, and his information has been confirmed by everything we learned since then," Glimmer said.

"So far, yes."

The General had a point, of course. But even if they learned more about Loki's crimes, Sam didn't think the Etherians would go back on their word. That wasn't how they did things.

Unless Loki went back on his word first. Or committed a crime or otherwise betrayed their trust.

She couldn't help wondering if Loki was aware of that - or if he thought the Etherians would forgive future deeds as easily as they did past deeds. If he did, he might be in for a rude awakening.

As would be anyone else who didn't understand that the Etherians gave second chances to everyone but expected you to change and stay changed once you took them, she added to herself with a glance at the diplomats in the room.

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"...and I do think we need to consider the fact that the Asgard don't want the Alliance's help more strongly if we want to come to an accommodation with them to secure our, ah, flanks." The American diplomat nodded.

Catra sighed. Those diplomats didn't get it. If someone needed help, Adora and the other princesses would help them. Whether they wanted the help or not. Heh, if Adora had managed to capture Catra in Thaymor, they would have probably done their best to help her. And she would have needed the help. But whether they would have succeeded… Bah, there was no sense in dwelling on the past.

She finished her last fish snack and looked at the diplomats, all lined up on one side of the largest table facing the princesses and SG-1. "What we need is more information," she said. "We can't really make plans without knowing more about the Asgard."

"We can make contingency plans," Adora objected - as Catra had expected; her lover was fond of planning. And overplanning. The stories she had heard from Bow and Glimmer about her plans for the Princess Prom…

"Waste of time," Catra retorted.

"It would be helpful to know more so we can correctly interpret the Asgard's statements," Daniel said. "We can't solve this misunderstanding if we create more misunderstandings. And we can't avoid provoking them -. Or pushing them into an action both sides will regret - if we don't know where they draw their lines."

"Well, we don't know that because they don't tell us that," Glimmer said.

"Unless we already crossed those lines by helping Loki," Sha're pointed out.

That was a good point, Catra had to admit. If the Asgard wouldn't budge on that and were just trying to use diplomacy before they resorted to force… Well, then it would end badly since the Princess Alliance wouldn't back down.

"Being unwilling to compromise wouldn't be very diplomatic," the British envoy said.

“Everyone has some things they won’t abandon or compromise about.” Jack shrugged.

“Of course,” Daniel said. “And the Asgard have been very close-lipped about such things.”

“Which is also a diplomatic tactic. Like our stance towards Taiwan. We keep China guessing how we would respond to an attack on the island so they won’t attack,” the American said.

“That sounds weird,” Glimmer said.

Catra nodded. She would have said ‘stupid’, but if it was working, who was she to judge?

“It has worked well.”

“So far,” Jack added. “And it also means that we can’t support Taiwan as much as we might want to.”

“We have an agreement with Loki,” Glimmer repeated herself.

“But would the Alliance go to war over it?” the German diplomat asked.

“As we were told, technically, the agreement is between the Kingdom of Bright Moon and Loki,” the American assistant, Weir, pointed out. “And the Asgard aren’t the Goa’uld. That is why we are merely observing here.”

“Yes,” Glimmer said, narrowing her eyes.

She didn’t deny that an attack by the Asgard wasn’t covered by the Alliance against the Goa’uld. But Catra knew that if Earth wanted to stay out of such a conflict using technicalities, the Alliance was dead anyway - the Princesses didn’t do things like that. Not the ones of the Princess Alliance. No matter what the Alliance treaty said. “I don’t think the Asgard would bother with sorting out which of our forces would defend Etheria and which wouldn’t if they go to war,” Catra said.

“Nevertheless, fighting a war to protect a criminal - someone who has, as we know, admitted to breaking the laws of his species - wouldn’t be very popular on Earth,” the American said.

“The Asgard haven’t even hinted at the threat of war so far,” Daniel said. “They have been appealing at our, well, morality. Or common sense, if you want to interpret their warnings about Loki like that. We shouldn’t assume the worst.”

“But we can’t assume everything will be fine,” Jack objected.

“That’s why we need data!” Entrpata repeated her earlier words. “And why the Asgard need data. Even if they don’t want it.”

“We know that we know nothing.” Daniel nodded. “The question is: Do the Asgard?”

“They are an old species,” Sha’re said. “They should be aware that they don’t know enough about Earth and the Alliance. However…” She glanced at Adora and Jack. “They have a history with the Gate Builders, or so they claimed. And you are the descendants of the Gate Builders.”

“But would they consider us Ancients? We don’t share their culture or claim that heritage,” Daniel said. “We don’t know very much about the Ancients’ culture to begin with.”

“And what we know about the First Ones isn’t good,” Catra added. Bunch of ruthless imperialistic bastards.

“If they think we are like the First Ones…” Adora winced.

“The way we showed Thor Alpha might have given the impression that we kind of succeeded the First Ones,” Bow said.

Jack snorted. “And if their impression of Earth’s culture is a tribe of Vikings, they might expect us to raid and plunder them.”

“I think that’s another misunderstanding to deal with. A potential misunderstanding,” Glimmer said. “Once the talks resume, we

should focus on getting to know each other."

Catra snorted at the unintended double-entendre, but Daniel nodded eagerly. "Yes! A cultural exchange. Or something like that. Provided they are willing, of course."

"Earth has been asking for such exchanges for quite some time," Weir pointed out.

And Etheria had stalled them. For a variety of reasons. Good reasons. As their movies and TV shows and everything else showed, too many humans were crazy. And dangerous. But if they could have a cultural exchange with the Asgard, they wouldn't be able to deny Earth one. Still…

"Best have that exchange with Etheria," Catra said with a snort. "I don't know if they would trust us any better if they visited Earth."

The others laughed at that, but Catra wasn't completely joking.

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Gate Area, Undesignated Asgard World, November 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and we will discuss your proposal in the High Council," Thor told them. "Such a decision necessitates careful deliberation."

"And all the data," Entrapta mumbled, though the Asgard didn't react to that, Jack O'Neill noticed.

Thor hasn't mentioned the rest of the Asgard, Jack thought. It seemed that the council would decide this, not the entire population. Not too unexpected - that was how things were run in the USA as well - but at least back home, the government was elected by the people. Indirectly, as Daniel would point out, but that was a technicality. Still, having your government decide whether your species lived or died - which this came down to, in his opinion - didn't sit right with Jack.

Glimmer nodded in response. “Of course. However, we have another proposal for you that shouldn’t need a lengthy discussion and could influence your decision. We invite you to visit Etheria and study us - our culture, our people - to better understand us and our friends.”

Once more, the Asgard seemed surprised, judging by the glances they exchanged.

“You’ve seen the research station of the first ones, but you haven’t seen our world,” Glimmer went on. “You don’t know us. We understand that without knowing more about us, you cannot trust us, and we want to change that.”

“We have nothing to hide,” Adora added, smiling brightly.

“Except for military secrets, of course,” Catra added.

Adora nodded. “Yes, that goes without saying.”

For all her idealism, she had been raised as an officer in the Horde, Jack reminded himself. She was familiar with information security.

“You already know about our base technology anyway,” Entrapta added, “since you knew Horde Prime.”

“Yes.” Thor nodded after a moment, which might mean he didn’t know as much about Horde technology as Entrapta assumed. But if he didn’t, he probably was too proud to admit it. Or he was just a little distracted by their offer of a cultural exchange.

“And how much access to your world would we have?” Freyr asked.

“That depends on the individual kingdoms, but you will have full access outside the military areas to Bright Moon and Dryl, and I can’t see our friends in the Princess Alliance refusing you access either,” Glimmer said. “I can’t speak for the kingdoms not associated with us, though.”

“Like Earth, your planet has no unified government but is dominated by an alliance of the strongest countries?” Freyr tilted his head.

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded.

Jack could see that the diplomats stirred a little at that. Probably took offence at Glimmer being so blunt about it even if she was correct - the NATO countries dominated Earth, now more than ever, with the Alliance technology spreading amongst them.

“Although said dominance is limited by treaties and international law,” Daniel pointed out. “Neither world is a dictatorship.”

Freyr looked at Anise next.

“The Tok’ra do not have a home world,” she said. “Our fight against the Goa’uld necessitates constant moving of our bases to avoid detection. At this point, we are not willing to compromise our security by revealing our bases to outsiders.”

“We wouldn’t expect you to,” Thor commented.

“This is about our agreement with Loki, anyway,” Glimmer said. “Earth and the Tok’ra are our allies against the Goa’uld, which is why they are present, but the only countries directly concerned are Bright Moon and the Princess Alliance of Etheria.”

“And the Asgard,” Penegal added.

“Of course,” Glimmer didn’t quite frown, but her smile grew a bit strained.

“So, will you visit?” Entrapt leaned forward.

“We will have to discuss this with the High Council,” Freyr said.

“Ah.” Entrapta pouted, but Glimmer nodded before she could comment further. “Of course. So, will you contact us when you’ve made a decision?”

"Yes."

And that was it. A few polite goodbyes later, they were back on PZ-1875. Catra made a point of stretching her arms over her head as they walked down the gate ramp. "Now, that was a long meeting with nothing to show for it," she complained.

"We learned more about the Asgard, and we made two important offers," Glimmer disagreed.

"We mostly learned that we don't know anything about them," Catra said.

"Which is generally an important lesson," Daniel said. "Being aware of such ignorance prevents decisions made in ignorance. Or it should," he added.

"Let's hope the Asgard share that view," Jack said.

"They didn't seem to want all the data they could have," Entrapta pointed out. "That's not a good sign."

"Well, that's not really that unique. A lot of politicians don't like data that contradicts them either," Jack said.

"They're not very good politicians, then," Entrapta commented.

The diplomats laughed at that together with the others, but they didn't sound too honest about it. Probably struck too close to home, in Jack's opinion.

Not that he cared. He was a soldier, not a politician or a diplomat. The politicking he had to do as a general was already bad enough.

He just wanted to fight the snakes without having to fight half the generals on his side. Well, except for the admirals, maybe.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, November 26th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and so we hope that the High Council of the Asgard will accept our invitation and send a delegation to Etheria," Glimmer finished.

Adora nodded in agreement, but not everyone in the Princess Alliance seemed to share her views. Perfuma, of course, was beaming with obvious enthusiasm, which meant Scorpia would be on board as well, but Mermista seemed more sceptical, as did Frosta. Netossa and Spinnerella seemed interested, but they weren't ruling princesses.

"So, we need to convince the Asgard that they should let us save their species?" Frosta asked with a frown.

"We would settle for convincing them that they shouldn't start a war with us over this," Glimmer replied.

"They're currently fighting those Replicators," Memista chimed in. "Since they're slowly winning, they can't be ready to fight another war. And last we heard, it'll take them a while to finish the robots - if all goes according to plan."

"Yes." Frosta nodded. "They can't do anything to us, and they can't help us in the war either, so why should we go to such lengths to placate them?"

"Because we don't want them as enemies only held back from attacking us by the demands of their current war," Glimmer said.

"The War against the Goa'uld will take a long time," Catra pointed out. "And even if we finish the snakes before the Asgard finish the Replicators, do you want to fight another war?" She scoffed, and Frosta glared at her.

"And we want to be friends with them," Entrapta added. "Loki's a great scientist! The Asgard have great technology - we could learn a lot from each other!"

“As long as you don’t learn *everything* from Loki,” Catra mumbled next to Adora.

Adora wanted to frown at her lover, but Catra was right. Loki wasn’t the best role model for ethical science. Quite the contrary.

Frosta pouted at that. “I still don’t like it.”

Mermista shrugged. “Meh. If they want a tour of Salineas, they can have one. But we won’t put on a show for them.”

“Oh!” Sea Hawk piped up. “But think of all the shanties they have never heard! And we can show them the thrills of…” He jumped on the table and raised his sword. “...ADVENTURE!”

“Sit down!” Glimmer snapped.

“We won’t show them an adventure!” Mermista hissed. “We don’t want them to think we’re trying to kill them!”

“But nothing invigorates you more and makes you appreciate your life than a harrowing brush with death!” Sea Hawk protested. “This could convince them to accept our help!”

“Or convince them that we’re dangerous lunatics,” Mermista retorted.

“My love!”

As the two bickered, and Glimmer fumed, Adora sighed. At least, it seemed as if Mermista had been convinced to allow this. And Frosta might still change her opinion once everyone else agreed. But that left another issue.

*****

“Alright. Now that that’s settled, there’s another related issue,” Glimmer continued ten minutes later. “Our allies on Earth have indicated that they, too, would like to open cultural exchanges with Etheria. More than we already have,” she added.

“Didn’t we host enough of their diplomats to fill a frigate?” Mermista asked. “And half my people are addicted to their ‘shows’.”

Adora frowned. That was hyperbole. Mostly.

“Don’t tell me they want to talk about embassies again!” Frosta groaned. “I won’t let them take part of my kingdom!”

“Technically, an embassy is still part of your kingdom,” Bow spoke up. “It just has certain protections according to their treaty.”

“A treaty which we didn’t sign,” Frosta retorted. “And won’t sign.”

“They have ambassadors at our courts; they don’t need an enclave for diplomacy,” Mermista said.

“It’s not about embassies,” Adora told them. “And it’s not about tourism either,” she added before anyone could bring that up - the documentaries about the effects of mass tourism on Earth had certainly had an impact on her friends. “It’s about cultural exchange - artists and scholars - to show us more about Earth and to learn more about Etheria.”

“We already know their culture,” Mermista said. “Earth TV shows are spreading everywhere.”

“Indeed!” Sea Hawk nodded. “Even in kingdoms where they are banned, smugglers will carry them.”

“Viewers that can display Earth media are one of our biggest exports,” Scorpia added. “Thank you again for sharing the design.” She nodded at Entrapta.

“But we don’t have such shows,” Glimmer said. “Earth doesn’t know as much about us as we do about them. They want to change that.”

“You mean they want to make TV shows about us.” Mermista closed her eyes. “Ugh.”

"Yes." Adora nodded. It was no secret that many journalists and TV companies had been asking for the opportunity to do that.

"We'll need a lot of guards to ensure they don't cause trouble," Netossa said. "Or run into trouble."

"Yes." Glimmer nodded with a frown.

Adora understood her friend. There were security concerns. Smuggling, spying. Recruiting. And getting eaten by monsters. But they could be dealt with. "We can handle it," she said. "And this will help us build more trust with Earth as well."

Something, as the latest news had shown, they still needed - many on Earth didn't like or trust them.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, November 26th, 1999

"So, the brass is unhappy with Earth being sidelined in the Alliance negotiations with the Asgard," the General said as he refilled his cup of coffee.

Sipping from her own cup - not quite as good as the coffee in her lab, if she were honest, but good nonetheless - Samantha Carter nodded. The Secretary of State had made a few comments expressing that sentiment on the way back to Earth.

"I thought they agreed that this was a matter between Etheria and the Asgard?" Daniel asked.

"That's their official stance," the General replied with a slight snort. "Unofficially, they're still smarting about the fact that they're not top dog any more, and some people think this mess with the Asgard is a great way to gain some influence or leverage."

Daniel frowned as he pushed his glasses up, Sha're mirrored his expression, and Teal'c didn't show any reaction, as usual. Sam

tried not to wince. “I don’t think the Etherians will like this - it’s sending conflicted messages.”

“Call it lying to their faces, Carter.” The General shrugged. “Or politics. Or diplomacy. Same things.”

Sha’re nodded in apparent agreement. Sam wasn’t surprised - Sha’re’s idea of politics and diplomacy had been formed by observing Amaunet.

Daniel, of course, didn’t. “The Etherians - the princesses in the Alliance, at least - prize honesty. Especially amongst their allies. I thought the government would have realised that - we’ve been working with the Princess Alliance for a long time by now.”

“The President surely knows that,” the General replied. “But not everyone in the government agrees that this means we should imitate Adora’s approach to diplomacy.” He shrugged again. “Anyway, that’s just office politics. Officially, our orders haven’t changed.”

“Since Adora is the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, changing orders against her will would be treason,” Teal’c commented.

“The American definition of treason is a bit stricter,” the General retorted, “but the sentiment is the same.”

Teal’c nodded.

“So… what do we do?” Daniel asked.

“Nothing. It’s all unofficial talk so far.” The General finished his cup.

“Shouldn’t we tell the Etherians?” Daniel frowned again.

“You mean leak internal information, Daniel?” The General’s eyebrows rose.

Sam rolled her eyes at his innocent act. He wouldn't have told them if he weren't planning to do something about it.

"To reveal dishonourable actions is not dishonourable," Teal'c stated.

"But if we do this, we expose ourselves as well," Sha're objected. "This could be a loyalty test."

"Oh." Daniel blinked. "You think this is a trap?"

The General shrugged. "It's a bit low-key for a trap. Nothing solid, nothing big, just rumours and sour grapes talk at the water cooler. But it could be a test to see where we stand."

"And where do we stand, Jack?" Daniel stared at him.

"We've sworn an oath to defend our country against all enemies, foreign and domestic."

"That's not an answer," Daniel complained. "And the Etherians aren't our enemies."

"Yep." The General was far too smug about such a delicate subject, in Sam's opinion. For all his complaints and comments about politics, he liked being clever a bit too much.

"I don't think we can classify our own government as a domestic enemy of our country," she commented.

"Of course not," the General agreed. "So, currently, we don't have enemies, foreign or domestic - except for the snakes, of course."

"And except for your rival countries on Earth, chiefly Russia and China," Sha're added.

"Ah… they aren't exactly enemies," the General told her. "Mostly because if they were our enemies, it wouldn't end well for them. Anyway, our job is to ensure that things stay like this. Except for the snakes, of course - there, our job is to defeat them."

Daniel frowned once more. “And what does that mean here?”

“Why, Daniel, something right up your alley: Promoting understanding between everyone!”

Sam smiled thinly. So, that was the reason the General had called them to his base to ‘discuss the latest mission’. “Are you referring to the planned cultural exchange between the Asgard and Etheria, sir?”

“And to Earth’s part in it.”

“You want us to take part in that?” Daniel seemed surprised.

“Do you know anyone who knows more about this? It’s sort of your thing, isn’t it, Daniel? And you can show Sha’re Etheria at the same time.”

Or use that as a cover, Sam finished the thought. And she would be expected to do her part as well - even though her best friend on Etheria was about the worst princess for this sort of thing she could think of.

“I guess so,” Daniel said, glancing at Sha’re.

Sha’re nodded at him. “We can do this.”

“Great!” The General clapped his hands. “Now, about our last mission…”

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, November 27th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“Still no reply from the Asgard…”

Catra snorted at the sigh from her lover. “Did you expect them to make such a decision - any decision - quickly?” She shifted on the chair in Adora’s office to curl up a bit more on the cushion and let

her tail dangle down over the armrest that was not serving as her headrest until she had the perfect position to read things on her tablet.

“Well…” Adora turned her head to look at her. “...yes?”

“The same people who are currently debating whether dying out is better than trying something new?”

Adora frowned at her. “That’s a bit unfair, isn’t it? We’re asking them to change their culture and genes.”

Of course, it was a bit unfair. But it was also, technically, correct. Catra flashed her fangs in a grin. “Everyone else has to do that as well. It’s called evolution and progress.” Or progress and evolution. Whatever.

“Not as drastically,” her lover retorted.

Carta frowned. “Did you change your opinion about helping them?”

“What? No! They need help, so of course we should help them! But I realised that they’re… like the Horde.”

“Like the Horde?” Catra blinked. How were the Asgard like the Horde?

“Not like that!” Adora frowned again. “I mean, they’ve been raised in their culture and don’t know anything else, so change is hard for them.”

Catra gave her a flat stare. “Everyone was raised in their culture - or a culture.” Like Adora and herself had been raised in the Horde as orphans.

“Yes, but the Asgard seem to be more conservative than… pretty much anyone we know.”

“Except for half of Earth,” Catra pointed out. “The half that hates our guts for being different. Or because they think their stupid god tells them so. And like the Asgard, they don’t want actual data to make decisions.”

“It’s not quite that bad…” Adora’s frown changed into a pout. “And Earth is changing - we know that.”

Catra nodded. Daniel had told them so, and Entrapta got the data. “They are still worse than the Asgard - and hate change even more.” Unless the Asgard were better at hiding things than they thought.

“Anyway, it’s a big step for them. We have to consider that.” Adora nodded. “But they’re not hurting anyone. Or trying to colonise planets.”

“That we know of,” Catra pointed out.

“They didn’t colonise Cimmeria,” Adora said.

“Unlike Earth.” Catra grinned. “At least they would if we let them.”

“Earth hates colonialism.”

“They say so,” Catra corrected her. Adora’s frown grew deeper, so she’d better not overdo it. “Anyway, we can’t do anything but wait until they call us.”

“I know…” Adora sighed again. “But we can prepare the cultural exchange. Even if the Asgard turn our invitation down, Earth is going to send a delegation to visit us.”

Catra was tempted to say ‘another delegation’ - they had had diplomats over - but that would be too much needling Adora. So, change of topic! “Do you think they’ll send actors over as well?”

“Actors?” Adora blinked. “Daniel said we’d get scholars and artists.”

“Actors are artists,” Catra said. “Though I guess we are already familiar with their art thanks to their movies and TV shows. Well, many of us, at least.”

Adora blinked again. “Oh…”

It was Catra’s turn to frown. “What?”

“We should ask them to send some actors - I think their fans here would love to meet them!” Adora beamed.

That was… well, not a bad idea. Still… Catra shrugged. “As long as it’s not one working on one of those catgirl shows, I don’t care. And if it is, I’ll claw them!”

“Catra! And those are cartoons, anyway.” Adora shook her head. “But I think this is a good idea. I’ll talk to Glimmer about this. Though we need to find out which actors are the most popular here.”

“And vet them,” Catra added.

Adora snorted. "I don't think actors are going to be a threat."

"Don't let Double Trouble hear that," Catra retorted. They were damned dangerous.

"That's different. Earth doesn't have anyone like them."

Catra sure hoped so.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, November 29th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“Hi, Jack. You wanted another meet… You’re watching the Simpsons?”

Jack O’Neill snorted as he turned towards Daniel - and Sha’re - who had just entered his office. “It’s for work.”

His friend blinked while Sha're moved to get a better look at the screen. "Work?"

"Cultural exchange, remember? The Etherians had a 'suggestion' about our delegation." Jack pointed at the screen where Homer was making another mess. "They wanted actors to visit."

"Oh." Daniel tilted his head slightly to the side. "That makes sense, I guess - movies and TV shows are a cornerstone of our culture. But that's a cartoon series."

"Voice actors count," Jack defended himself. "And they mentioned the Simpsons being popular on Etheria."

"Oh? I wouldn't have expected that. They have theatres, so live-action movies and shows seem to be a logical step, while they don't seem to have anything similar to cartoons. On the other hand, that might make them more appealing."

"Oh, it's not just cartoons," Jack admitted. "They also have a slew of other shows and movies they like. But I wanted to familiarise myself with the Simpsons," he added with a grin.

"Don't you know the series by heart?" Daniel asked, looking from Jack to the screen, then at Sha're, who was softly laughing at Bart's antics.

"I watched the series. I didn't study it." Jack shrugged. "But if that's part of how the Etherians have experienced our culture so far, I thought I should take a closer look." And rewatch some of the classics on the government's dime.

"Ah, yes." His friend nodded. "That is going to be very interesting - finding out what preconceptions the Etherians have after experiencing our culture mostly through media. And Western media, at that. Although most of their contact with Earth has been limited to Western countries anyway."

"Let's hope they don't take the Simpsons as an example of our culture," Jack joked.

Daniel didn't laugh - he frowned. "That is a danger. Probably not as much with cartoons, but the live-action shows might be mistaken to be closer to documentaries than fiction. And the various cultural references and assumptions won't be understood at all, of course, without the background of having grown up in our culture. When Japanese animation started becoming popular in the West, they often had additional material with the videos that explained Japanese culture so the viewers would have the context to understand the references. It's quite a challenge for translations."

Great. If the Etherians thought that the way families in sitcoms behaved was normal… Jack shook his head.

"Yes. It is often confusing," Sha're chimed in. "But it's still funny."

"Some humour is universal," Daniel agreed.

"And you always explain things to me, so I'm learning more about Earth."

"Of course!" Daniel beamed at her. "And you teach me more about the Goa'uld. Though we should check what shows and movies are popular on Etheria. And maybe introduce them to a few choice examples they might have missed."

"Sounds good. And Hollywood can start getting royalties from the Etherians." Jack chuckled.

Once again, Daniel winced. "Ah… that's actually a problem. The Etherians have no concept of trademarks or intellectual property laws. Quite understandable given their society and culture, of course - it's far more artisan in nature than Earth's industry. They value the work of creating something as much as the idea behind it - sometimes even more."

"They have factories."

"Yes - remnants of the Horde military-industrial complex, as far as I know. And the effects of those being turned to civilian

production might be interesting." Daniel nodded. "But they have no concept of intellectual properties. If they can copy something, they do it. Whether that's an idea for a new product or a media."

"They've been pirating Hollywood movies and shows?" Jack asked. Of course, they had - he had known they were copying and recording whatever media and news they could get, and their ships in orbit had full coverage. And soldiers would smuggle things back home, but there weren't that many Etherians on Earth… "How bad is it?"

Daniel winced. "I don't know exact numbers - the Etherians don't know either; I asked. But since it's all data, digitalised copies, it's easy to copy without any loss of quality. The limiting factor seems to be the electronics to view the media. And such viewers, or tablets, apparently are amongst the most popular products of the former Horde lands. And since there are only about fifty million people on the planet, they can probably cover the entire market quite quickly." He shrugged. "I think a lot of people still don't understand that the Etherians aren't a medieval culture just because some of their kingdoms have, ah, 'fantasy aesthetics'. It's probably just a question of time before they start producing their own movies and shows."

Jack snorted. "Hollywood won't like it. They want their cut."

"And that's another issue. In order to pay royalties, the Etherians would need to trade with Earth. Otherwise, their money would not be worth anything on Earth except for collectors and visitors to Etheria. Fungible goods could be a substitute, but that's trading," Daniel said. "And the Etherians probably won't open their countries to Earth's industry since we would flood their markets with our goods. The economic consequences would be… drastic."

"So Wall Street won't like it either," Jack said. But what could they do? And even if the Etherians agreed on cracking down on pirating - the electronic kind - could they stop it? Earth hadn't had a lot of success with that.

This cultural exchange thing was looking to be a lot more complicated than he had thought. And he had been quite pessimistic about it in the first place.

*****

Cultural Exchange Part 1

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, November 30th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and so we have accepted your offer. We will send a delegation consisting of three representatives of the Asgard High Council to visit your planet and examine your civilisation in depth at your earliest convenience."

Adora smiled as she listened to the recording of Thor's voice. This was great! "They've accepted our offer!"

"Yes." Glimmer's reaction was a bit more subdued than Adora had expected. Although she probably had seen the recording before - Adora had just returned from an inspection of the Alliance training camp in the Scorpion Kingdom.

Still, she better made sure everything was alright. "Is something wrong?" Something she could fix?

"No." Glimmer shook her head.

"Not wrong per se," Bow added. "But we're not quite as ready for their visit as we hoped to be."

"I thought everything was being prepared," Adora said, frowning.

"That was the plan, yes," Bow said. "But it's taking longer than we planned."

Catra cocked her head to the side. "Really? What's the problem? Is Princess Sweet Bee making noises about her lack of relevance again? Or are your people striking?"

"No." Glimmer shook her head with a snort. "Sweet Bee hasn't contacted us since her last complaint." With a frown aimed at Catra, she added: "Although once she hears about this, she'll

show up at once. And Prince Peekablue will notice this. Also, my people aren't striking - quite the opposite."

Huh? "What do you mean?" Adora asked.

"They are very enthusiastic," Bow explained while Glimmer grimaced. "We have far too many volunteers - and from outside Bright Moon as well. A lot of people want to meet the humans."

"And that is the problem. Part of it, at least - it seems everyone is fired up about meeting the humans." Glimmer pouted. "We don't have as many volunteers for the Asgard visit."

"So?" Catra shrugged. "As long as they are still doing what you tell them to do, where's the problem?"

"We want to make the best impression on the Asgard," Glimmer replied. "But if everyone is talking about the humans when the Asgard are here, that won't leave a good impression."

"That seems a bit far-fetched," Catra objected. "Besides, you don't need a lot of servants to handle three Asgard."

"It's not about the servants. It's about the scholars, musicians, artisans and sorceresses of Etheria," Glimmer said. "Most of them are eager to meet their human counterparts."

"Well, my Dads also want to meet the Asgard." Bow smiled.

But Glimmer didn't. "Because they want to ask them about the First Ones they might have met."

"Well, yes - but that's not any worse than wanting to meet the humans behind your favourite TV show," Bow retorted.

"Which your Dads also want." Glimmer sighed. "And Mermista and Frosta are still not fully on board. They'll receive the Asgard, but I don't know if they'll be very welcoming."

Adora winced. Frosta had a temper, and Mermista could be very mean when she didn't like you. "We need to talk to them."

"And to several scholars and artists," Glimmer said. "And we need to do it quickly, or the Asgard will get impatient."

"And we need to prepare for the visit from Earth as well - people are getting impatient already about meeting their favourite actors and musicians," Bow added.

Oh. Adora grimaced. She shouldn't have gone inspect a training camp - she should have worked on this!

"It's not your fault, you idiot," Catra said with a scoff as if she had read Adora's thoughts. "You didn't suggest this."

"But I didn't contradict Daniel, either," Adora objected. And she had agreed with his plan. It was a good plan, anyway, even if they had hit a bit of snag. They just needed a plan to pull this off. "Let's make a plan!"

"How to hype the Asgard?" Catra asked.

"Yes?" Adora smiled when Catra grumbled. "We need to make people enthusiastic about meeting the Asgard. Honestly enthusiastic."

"We know nothing about the culture of the Asgard," Glimmer pointed out.

"We can ask Loki about that. He probably has a huge collection of Asgard movies, songs and TV shows," Adora said."There's bound to be things that will interest people!"

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 1st, 1999 (Earth Time)

Adora stared at the screen for a few seconds after the recording had ended. “How many were those?” she asked.

“That was the fifteenth,” Bow replied. He sounded far too happy for what they were doing.

“Don’t tell me you actually like that stuff. Watching paint dry would be more interesting,” Catra complained from Adora’s lap, where she had rested her head halfway through the recording.

“It’s… interesting. It offers us insight into a completely different culture,” Bow replied.

“A completely boring culture,” Catra retorted. “I think we should reconsider saving the Asgard. The universe won’t miss them.”

Adora frowned at her lover. She knew Catra was joking, but that wasn’t a laughing matter. “They have great scientific knowledge,” she said.

“And the worst entertainment I’ve ever seen. Don’t tell me you liked any of the recordings we checked.”

Adora winced. Finding anything about the Asgard to catch the interest of the Etherian people was a bit harder than she had thought. Though this was probably Loki’s fault - they only had his favourite media to examine, after all. And he was hardly a representative member of his species.

*****

Space Lab, Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 1st, 1999 (Earth Time)

“...so, apparently, Asgard culture is boring. At least the things Loki likes. I don’t understand it - I didn’t enjoy the songs or the epics, as he called them, but I also don’t enjoy some of the Earth media we collected, yet others like them. Very much, actually, so much they really want to meet the creators and actors, which actually is the problem we have with the Asgard since people don’t want to

see the Asgard creators. Which would be a little hard, anyway, since even with their cloning technology, most of the creators are dead, so that would be a dead end anyway."

Samantha Carter nodded as Entrapta rambled while her hair manipulated the latest experiment. So, the Etherians found the Asgard culture boring but were fans of Earth media.

"I do not think Loki is a good example for the taste of the average Asgard," Hordak added, looking up from his console. "He is, according to their High Council and himself, a renegade. As such, he obviously doesn't share the opinions of the majority of his people, or he would have mentioned that in an attempt to get Earth to support him in a potential populist coup against the High Council."

That was… a very peculiar view of Loki's motivations. But Sam couldn't honestly claim that Hordak was completely off base - painting the High Council of the Asgard as some oligarchy oppressing the common people would have rang a note with certain human politicians. Although Loki might not have realised that since he primarily interacted with Etherians, who had a quite different take on ruling systems, and his contact with humans hadn't been entirely positive.

She sighed. As Daniel had often mentioned in the last few days, they simply didn't know enough about the Asgard to tell. "He might have lied about that anyway," she pointed out. Most revolutionaries tended to overestimate their popular support.

"Which supports my deduction," Hordak said in a smug voice.

"But you can't assume that a difference in political views also means a difference in entertainment," Sam retorted.

"In a society as hide-bound as the Asgard's?" Hordak shook his head. "I do not think I am wrong."

You don't think that often anyway, Sam added silently.

“So, it could be that the Asgard have other media that would appeal to us!” Entrapta smiled. “Although that’s not helpful to getting a better welcome for the delegation since we can’t get their media until we have decent relations. Unless we manage to get a spy bot into the range of their transmissions and can download their media that way,” she added with a smile.

That idea was problematic on several levels, Sam knew that. “I think they would see an attempt by us to find and infiltrate their systems as a hostile act,” she pointed out. “And copying their media is also a bit questionable.” Not to mention illegal in many places on Earth.

“Copying freely broadcasted transmissions is not illegal on Earth,” Hordak retorted.

“But redistributing them is,” Sam told him.

“On Earth.” Hordak’s mouth twisted into a thin smile.

“It’s stupid anyway,” Entrapta chimed in. “Information should be free!”

“Within limits,” Hordak disagreed. “Military information is obviously exempt from that, but certain scientific knowledge is also best kept from those who would abuse it.”

Sam nodded. She didn’t like it, but she had to agree with Hordak. “Yes. But there’s also the problem of reimbursing the creator of copied media. They spent time and effort, and often money, on their work. Others should not be able to take it for free.”

“But didn’t they get paid for it already?” Entrapta looked confused. “Most of the artists - and the scientists - on Earth are employed, right? So, they got paid for their work already.”

“Yes, but their employer wasn’t,” Sam said.

“But they’re not the actual creator!” Entrapta protested. “They’re just the sponsor.”

“Patron,” Hordak added. “And often, it’s the government financing the work, like at your universities.”

Sam winced. Trying to explain how Earth copyright and patent law worked wasn’t something she wanted to do any more than she wanted to go into the details of academic research.

“And for science, sharing of research is essential! We can achieve a lot more working together and building upon each other’s results than working alone in secret!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “We’ve proven that on Etheria!”

But Etheria wasn’t Earth. “A lot of research on Earth is privately funded,” Sam explained. “As is most of the entertainment. And those who grant the funding want to make a profit from their investment.”

“That doesn’t sound like a very effective way to do science,” Entrapta said, frowning. “And if they don’t want to share their entertainment media, why broadcast it where everyone with a receiver can pick it up?”

Sam sighed again.“They usually only do that once they have shown the media in theatres. Or they get reimbursed by subscription payments or advertising money.”

“That doesn’t sound like they care a lot about their work,” Entrapta said. “And that doesn’t work for science anyway.”

“I have to concur,” Hordak said. “This system seems prone to abuses and unintended consequences through the incentives it creates.”

Daniel would love debating this, Sam thought. And he would love talking about what such debates reveal about us - and to us. But she wasn’t Daniel. She was a scientist and wanted to focus on that. “So far, it has worked on Earth,” she said. Not perfectly, but well enough. No system was perfect.

“Well, we do things differently on Etheria,” Entrapta said. “And it has worked for us.”

But would they be able to work together? That was the question. And Sam didn’t think she had an answer.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“We should have waited another day. Prepared some more. Maybe we would have found a song or epic that isn’t boring, weird, or both.”

Catra rolled her eyes at Adora’s fretting. “Do you really believe that? We went through far too many of Loki’s recordings, and they were all bad. Even Bow admitted that.” And Bow was far too nice to say that lightly, even if it was true.

“Well…” Adora trailed off, pouting. “I just think we could have done more.”

“You always think that.” Catra snorted. “You’d think you could have done more, done better, no matter how well something went.”

“Complacency breeds failure,” Adora replied - and froze a moment later, looking guilty.

Catra clenched her teeth together for a second. That had been one of Shadow Weaver’s lessons. Adora was still suffering from the effects of having been raised by that woman. So was Catra, of course, but she was handling it. And ignoring it. “I think we did what we could, given what we know,” she said.

Adora slowly nodded. “Hopefully.” Then she checked the time. “Shouldn’t be long now. They already arrived at the temporary base.”

It wouldn’t be long, indeed - unless the scans at the base detected something amongst the Asgard delegation. That would delay things. And probably cause a diplomatic crisis or a war, depending on what it was.

But no alert came from the comm nearby, connected to the spy bot network. Catra still checked the comm personally when the request to open the gate arrived - trust, but verify. That lesson hadn’t been one of Shadow Weaver’s; the woman had never trusted anyone. Or deserved any trust herself.

But the signs, countersigns and codes matched. “It checks out,” Catra told Adora - and Glimmer, who was hurrying over to their spot from where she had been checking the uniforms of the gate guards.

“Raise the Gate!” Glimmer ordered, and the Gate smoothly rose out of its pit into a standing position.

As soon as it was ready, Catra gave the all-clear on the comm. A moment later, the Stargate activated. Cutting it a bit close, she thought - they would have started dialling before they got her message to be that fast. Were they trying to impress the Asgard with speed and efficiency? She wouldn’t put it past the soldiers stationed there, but Netossa and Spinnerella should be less reckless.

The vortex collapsed, and the wormhole stabilised. A few seconds passed, then two guards in Bright Moon uniform stepped through, followed by three Asgard. Thor, Freyr and Penegal. She briefly wondered if the fact that they were meeting with the same three Asgard would tell them something about the species’s culture. Focus, she reminded herself as she followed Adora to meet the Asgard at the foot of the ramp.

“Welcome to Bright Moon.” Gimmer nodded at them.

“And Welcome to Etheria!” Adora added with a bright smile.

Catra had to suppress the urge to add a smart-ass comment. This was an important diplomatic meeting.

The Asgard looked around. "Are there no representatives from Earth?" Freyr asked.

"They'll join us later," Glimmer told them with a diplomatic smile. "This is about showing you Etherian culture."

Alliance culture, Catra silently corrected her. If they showed the Asgard the culture of the Crimson Waste, they would probably consider it an act of war. Both the Asgard and the Crimson Waste.

She had to suppress a snort at that thought as they walked past the lines of guards standing at attention to the skiffs that would take them to Glimmer's palace.

"Are those ceremonial weapons?" Penegal asked, eyeing the spears with open curiosity.

"No," Glimmer told them. "They are also still in use where melee combat is expected."

Or crowd control, but that worked out the same, Catra added to herself. They were pretty useless, though - and the less said about the proposal to replace them with an Etherian version of the Goa'uld staff weapons, the better. Catra would have expected better sense from the Princess Alliance - they had used any Horde laser rifles they could get their hands on quite effectively during the war.

Freyr nodded, though it wasn't clear what he thought about that. Well, he'd see different soldiers when they visited the Scorpion Kingdom.

Thor and Penegal looked at the skiffs with interest as well. "Magitech," Penegal said. "Is that in common use?"

"Etheria never lost its magic," Glimmer reminded them. "The skiff itself is relatively common, but most people use at least some

magitech in their daily lives."

"Ah." Thor nodded. "You said that you are descendants of the Gate Builders - the Ancients - who used Etheria for their experiments."

Glimmer kept smiling. Very diplomatic. "Yes."

"Yet, your technology is not very similar to theirs." Penegal cocked his head sideways.

"We built our own," Glimmer said.

"George - my Dad, one of my Dads - wrote an essay about the development of magitech on Etheria, if you're interested," Bow added.

"I am." Penegal nodded.

Bow beamed at him and started fiddling with his tablet while the Asgard climbed into the first skiff, together with Glimmer and Adora.

Catra followed them. That was pushing the skiff's carrying capacity a bit, but they'd be fine - the Asgard didn't weigh too much.

Besides, someone had to pilot it, and having the Queen of Bright Moon or the Supreme Commander of the Alliance doing it probably wouldn't really impress their guests - it would look far too forced. At least in Catra's opinion.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"I would have never expected to be able to travel to another planet in my lifetime!"

"What? Not even after First Contact? It won't cost a lot to step through a portal!"

"It's called a Stargate, not a portal."

"What's the difference?

"A portal is science fiction or fantasy; a Stargate is real!"

Jack O'Neill glanced at Carter and grinned. His second-in-command had the expression she usually showed when she was struggling not to correct a superior who was using imprecise or plain wrong technical terms. All polite, but her eyes just had that 'why me?' expression shining through.

Granted, none of the actors and artists gathered in the room next door - unaware that they could observe them - was actually her superior. No matter what some of the arrogant idiots clearly thought. But their orders were to be polite to their guests anyway. At least until they found an excuse to boot the worst of them.

"Anyway, I expected space tourism to start much sooner."

"Really? We're at war with a galactic empire, and you want to play tourist?"

"We didn't stop travel on Earth so why shouldn't we travel the galaxy?

"Because the Stargate is vital for the war effort?"

Someone amongst the bunch has a little common sense, Jack thought.

"It's not a spaceship - you just step through it, and whoosh! You're on another planet. That's not going to take a lot of time at all."

"Besides, if it were so vital, they wouldn't let us travel to another planet, would they? Back in World War II, they had rationing. We

don't have that now, so things can't really be that bad."

"They still won't let me buy a space shuttle!"

I got a personal stealth shuttle, Jack thought with a grin.

"Why would they let you have a shuttle?"

"I've got money."

"Shuttles are vital for the war effort."

"One shuttle more or less won't make a difference."

"And we're also vital for the war effort, or we wouldn't be here!"

"Someone has a high opinion of themselves," Jack commented.

"All of them are famous artists, Jack." Daniel shook his head. "And they've just been told that they are so popular on Etheria that the Alliance requested their participation in the upcoming cultural exchange program. Of course, they'll feel important - they are important."

"But not as important as they think they are," Jack retorted with a snort.

"Indeed." Teal'c nodded.

His friend was hard to read, but Jack thought Teal'c was a bit annoyed as well - and he should be. He should be with his family, not meeting a bunch of overpaid actors and musicians so the shrinks and spooks could judge how they would react to Etherians.

"Well, I think we've let them wait long enough to spot the first problem children," Jack said.

"Yes." Daniel pointed at the most arrogant actor in the next room. "I don't think the Etherians will react well to his sense of

entitlement and his lack of care about the war, but I'll still need to talk to him in person."

"And try to find out if his sense of entitlement extends to sex," Jack reminded him. The last thing they needed was an actor hitting on a princess and not taking no for an answer. No, he corrected himself a moment later, the last thing we need is an asshole seducing a princess and ending up their prince-consort or whatever the term was. "Yeah, let's go and talk to our future cultural ambassadors. Try not to murder them, folks!"

"Jack!" Daniel exclaimed, but Jack was already moving to the door to the meeting room.

"Hello, everyone!" he said as soon as he stepped inside. "I am General Jack O'Neill, and this is my team. Dr Daniel Jackson, Major Samantha Carter and Teal'c. We're going to brief you about Etheria."

"Finally!" Mr 'I want a personal space shuttle' cried out, almost spilling his drink. "We've been waiting for hours!"

Half an hour, tops. But Jack smiled anyway. "Sorry about that," he lied. "Things came up. We're fighting a war. Anyway, you're here because we're going to launch a cultural exchange program with Etheria, and you're potential members of our delegation."

"I thought the Etherians specifically requested us?" a singer asked. Jack didn't know her or her music, but according to Daniel, she was one of the artists who wrote their own songs, which was supposed to vibe well with the Etherians.

She was polite as well, so Jack nodded. "They gave us a list of artists who are popular on their world. But we still have to vet all of you."

"'Vet'?" Another guy, already a bit into his cups, or so it looked, asked.

"Check if you are a security risk," Jack told him with a toothy smile. "We don't want a diplomatic incident. You're going to meet and greet a lot of powerful people, and we'd rather not have to smooth out things if you end up in a duel after insulting a princess. Or dead." He shrugged.

"Dead?" The man blinked, lowering his drink. "But… they're our allies, aren't they?"

"Yes, they are. They are also a totally different culture, and they've been through a decades-long war that only ended a year or two ago." Jack grinned again.

"But… duels?"

They were paying attention now, Jack noted with satisfaction. He nodded at Daniel.

His friend took a step forward and cleared his throat. "Well, it's not as if Etheria has a formal duelling culture, like Earth had in the past, but it's a world divided into individual kingdoms ruled by absolute monarchs - who all have magic powers and are generally expected to personally fight in a war to defend their people, so their first impulse is not to call for the police, but to settle matters personally. That doesn't mean they'll react violently to a misunderstanding, but depending on the situation, things could escalate rather quickly, and so …"

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Bright Moon, Etheria, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and this is Bright Moon."

Adora watched the Asgard's reaction to Glimmer's announcement. There was no awe, no wonder, just polite - probably - interest as they studied the city ahead of them. It was completely unlike her own reaction years ago. Or SG-1's.

"What purpose serves the artificial waterfall?" Freyr asked.

“It is nice to look at,” Glimmer replied in her ‘I am being polite but I wish I didn’t have to’ voice.

“Ah.” Freyr nodded as if that was a profound piece of knowledge. Maybe it was for the Asgard - they would have been raised very differently than Adora or anyone else she knew.

“You mentioned a war on this planet before the invasion by Horde Prime. Was the city ever attacked?” Thor looked around as they entered the gate.

Was he trying to spot defences? Or battle damage? And was she starting to think a bit too much like Catra - or Jack?

“Yes, a few times, but the shield held,” Glimmer explained.

Although only barely, Adora knew. Catra’s first attack had almost shattered it, and Horde Prime could have destroyed it from orbit easily if he had focused on it.

“Is it a magitech shield?” Penegal asked.

“Yes.” Glimmer didn’t add ‘of course’, but Adora heard it anyway.

“You have an eclectic mix of technologies,” the Asgard went on as they passed a floating wagon drawn by a horse.

Oh - Ketro and Jesa were on the wagon, probably transporting their produce to the market. She waved at them, and the two farmers waved back.

“It works for us,” Glimmer said. “And people are used to it.”

“So, it’s tradition? And not a result of your war?” Freyr cut in.

“Mostly tradition,” Glimmer admitted. “The Horde War caused a lot of changes, but most of them were limited to the military.”

“And horses are great,” Adora added. “A skiff doesn’t have a personality.”

“According to the tech pool in the Horde, some vehicles had a nasty personality,” Catra cut in as she steered the skiff towards the palace gates. “Not as bad as Swift Wind, of course.”

“Catra!” Adora frowned at her lover. Swift Wind was a great friend!

“Did someone say Swift Wind?” And there he was, swooping down from the sky to land next to them. “Hello!”

The Asgard stared. “Hello,” Freyr said after a moment.

“Are you flying thanks to an innate magical power, or do you have anti-gravity implants?” Penegal asked. “Your wings are not large enough to lift your body - unless it’s much lighter than a horse’s.”

That sounded a little rude to Adora. But they were obviously surprised by her friend, so that excused it. Partially, at least. Or maybe that wasn’t rude by their standards - Loki acted the same if something interested him, after all.

And Swift Wind wasn’t offended. “Oh, it’s magic! When Adora created me, she granted me a part of her power! A sign of the sacred bond that links us!”

And now all of the Asgard were staring at her, Adora noticed. “Uh… I was new to my power and was experimenting,” she explained.

They were still staring. Harder, even, or so it seemed. Oh! She blushed. “I wasn’t trying to create Swift Wind, or anything - I was just trying to, ah, unlock my sword’s power.”

“And you accidentally created a new sapient life form?” Adora could clearly hear Thor’s sarcasm.

She still nodded. “Yes.” That was the truth, after all.

“That’s Adora for you,” Catra added. “Creating flying unicorns and space plants by accident.”

“Space plants?” Penegal cocked his head to the side.

“I turned Horde Prime’s flagship into a plant. In space,” Adora explained. “There was the power of the Heart of Ethera, all the magic the First Ones had been collecting, and I had to send it somewhere…”

The three Asgard didn’t look like they believed her. Even if it was the truth again.

“You can see it from here when its orbit takes it above Bright Moon,” Glimmer said. “We can also take you up in a shuttle if you want a closer look.”

“I think we would like a closer look at this ‘space plant’, yes,” Thor said.

“Does it grow in space? Spread?” Freyr asked.

Oh, no. “It’s harmless,” Adora assured them. “Perfuma checked, and she is the greatest expert on plants on Etheria - she can control any plant. Even cactuses. The space plant just absorbs sunlight and, well, exists.”

Unfortunately, it didn’t seem as if the Asgard believed her about that either.

The cultural exchange wasn’t up to a good start, and it was all her fault.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“...and that’s a brief overview of the Etherian social and economic structure.”

Samantha Carter suppressed a smile when Daniel finished his lecture. Her friend was an academic at heart, and it always

showed when he was briefing people. And, she added to herself when she looked at the assembled actors and artists in the room, those people are, by and large, not academics, and it shows.

"So… basically medieval kings and queens?" an actor Sam wouldn't have recognised without her own briefing since she wasn't a fan of his movies asked.

Daniel blinked. "No, as I just said, the similarities are only superficial. There is no feudal system, for one. The absolute monarchs of the Renaissance would be a better comparison, especially those championing Enlightenment, but even there, we have critical differences in the social and political structure, for example, the general lack of an entrenched noble class. In fact, the princesses, despite being defined so by their inherited power, both magical and legal, are remarkably free of class or caste biases when choosing their partners or consorts."

"So, they're like Walt Disney princesses," an actress who had played in Disney movies joked, and most of the room chuckled.

"Walt Disney princesses in a Tarantino movie," the General's remark cut through the fading laughter. "They went through a bloody war against a literal evil Horde, and they fought in the trenches." He pointed at the group picture of the Princess Alliance displayed on the screen behind Daniel. "See that little girl in front? She can freeze you into a solid block of ice. And she isn't some comic superhero who won't kill - she's fought and killed enemies despite her age."

The actors looked quite taken aback at that. "But she's a teenager!" another actress protested. "She looks like she's barely in high school!"

"Etheria doesn't have the same values and customs as we have," Daniel spoke up again. "They are more liberal than most countries on Earth in some areas, such as gay marriage, but that doesn't mean that they share everything that we Americans would consider liberal values."

“Aren’t they all about forgiveness and rehabilitating? Even their former enemies.” An actor with the biggest ego of anyone Sam had ever met, and that included both generals and politicians of the highest ranks, shook his head. “That sounds very liberal to me. We would have nailed those bastards to the wall.”

Daniel frowned and pushed his glasses up. “That’s another misconception. This Etherian policy - custom would be more precise - is rooted as much or more in what we would call pragmatism or realpolitik as it is in personal views and ideals. By sparing the leaders of an enemy kingdom, they ensure that wars aren’t prolonged unnecessarily because the losing side is fighting for their ranks, freedom or even life - which also means they can expect the same should they lose.”

“They aren’t some naive girls who only see the good in people,” the General added. “They are veterans.”

Sam nodded in agreement. Of course, some of them might seem a bit naive, such as Perfuma and Scorpia. But for all their sweet tempers, they were terrifying in combat.

“They are honourable warriors,” Teal’c said.

“Does that mean they will challenge us to a duel if they feel their honour was insulted?” That came from an actor who had a reputation as a womaniser. Although he, like everyone else present, had already passed a background check, so there was nothing unsavoury about it. Or shouldn’t be - nobody was perfect. And the way he had checked out Sam when they had introduced themselves had felt uncomfortably familiar.

“They might do that - or they might just attack you or punish you,” Daniel said. “Remember: They have a different culture, and they are absolute rulers of their country.”

“And the US government won’t be able to bail you out if you piss them off too badly.” The General grinned.

A few of the actors and singers seemed to have second thoughts about this 'tour'. Unfortunately, the ones with the biggest egos didn't seem to be amongst them.

*****

Fifteen minutes later, they were 'mingling' with their guests, and what fear of Etheria Daniel inadvertently and the General deliberately had induced in the artists was fading again.

"So, Major Carter - Carter was it, right? - You've been talking about princesses all day. Aren't there any princes?" The lead actress of a sitcom Sam was not familiar with asked.

"There are princes - like Prince Peekablue," she replied, "but the majority of the rulers are female, and when people say 'princesses' on Etheria, they mean both female and male rulers."

"Sounds like a feminist dreamland!" The arrogant actor that they had listened to before entering the room chuckled.

"They have a remarkably egalitarian view of genders," Sam said with a slight frown.

"For absolute monarchs, I suppose." The man shrugged. "People in power always have more privileges.

The actress frowned. "Is that true?"

"It permeates their entire society," Sam reassured her. "Men and women are equal on Etheria - at least in the kingdoms we visited."

"Ah."

"And yet, there are more princesses than princes!" The man snorted. "That doesn't sound very equal to me."

Sam schooled her features. "That might be a result of how magic powers are inherited. We don't know too much about how their society came to be and how magic talents are passed on."

“Speaking of magic talents…” An actress who played teenagers in TV shows smiled at Sam over a drink she wouldn’t be allowed to have in the USA. “Can we get a test for magic talent on Etheria?”

Sam blinked. They hadn’t thought about that. “I am not sure,” she said. “Magic is generally handled by Mystacor, and they are a bit isolationist.”

“What? We can’t visit the flying magic academy?” The woman looked shocked.

“You will meet sorceresses,” Sam told her. “Both male and female ones,” she added with a side glance at the arrogant actor.

The man snorted again, and Sam made a mental note to bring up his attitude at the debriefing - he might be a potential problem on Etheria.

Unfortunately, he was not the only one with such an attitude by far.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“Say… are there horses on your planet?”

Catra was really tempted to ‘accidentally’ steer the skiff into Swift Wind. The stupid horse was about to ruin this event with his thoughtless chatter.

“No. We don’t have horses. We stopped using draft animals long before we achieved faster-than-light travel,” Freyr explained - in a tone that told Catra that he wasn’t impressed with the fact that Etheria still used them.

At least, that was her impression. They might just be wary of what they saw as another biological experiment. It was hard to read the Asgard, even with her experience working under Hordak. The Asgard were not like the clones. Fortunately, they also were

nothing like Horde Prime. Though Loki had some similarities, if you thought about it…

"Oh? That's a very enlightened attitude!" Swift Wind beamed at them. "I'm still working on freeing my fellow horses from bondage - here and on Earth. Could you tell me how you managed to convince your species to stop using draft animals?"

"Ah…" Adora winced. She must have picked up on the implications of Freyr's comment.

"They were too inefficient compared to more advanced technology," Freyr said.

"Oh. Then I don't understand why Etheria and Earth are still forcing horses to work - both planets have advanced transport technology!" Swift Wind complained. "And they aren't as traditional as you are."

"I am sorry to say that we cannot be of any help here - we do not know much about either planet's culture," Thor said. "We are here to learn more about Etheria's culture."

And that was a polite 'get lost' if Catra had heard any before.

"Oh. That's too bad."

Not that Swift Wind would get it, of course.

Catra glanced at Glimmer - Adora wouldn't send Swift Wind away, and the Asgard couldn't - but it seemed that the queen didn't mind their guests being bothered by a pushy horse. Probably still annoyed at their attitude and being petty about it.

Whatever, it was no skin off Catra's butt. Thanks to excellent timing, they had reached the palace gates, so she focused on parking the skiff while more guards lined up to welcome the queen and her friends and guests.

Swift Wind flew off with some cheery goodbye as they disembarked. Catra used the opportunity to check a suspicion. "You don't have former draft animals living free on your planet, do you?" she asked, bending slightly towards the three Asgard.

Thor looked at her. "You are correct."

Catra nodded.

Adora frowned. "How did that happen?"

"They had long since domesticated and had lost the ability to survive in the wild. Once the Asgard stopped caring for them, they logically died out," Freyr said.

"But…" Adora shook her head. "Couldn't you have kept them alive?"

"We could have, but why should we have? Their time had passed." Freyr tilted his head slightly to the left.

"Couldn't you have… bred them back into wild animals?" Adora asked.

"Why would we have done that? Their wild ancestors had died out already, and their ecological niche had been filled again." Freyr shook his head. "It was much more appropriate to let them die out."

"I take it you're not very sentimental about pets," Catra said in a dry voice.

"I'm not gonna let them near Luna," she heard Adora mutter.

Catra snorted. She didn't think the Asgard would hurt Luna. But their attitude was… weird. She was tempted to ask if they ever thought that the Asgard's time was passing as well, but that would have been rude. Probably.

It would explain their stance towards Loki's experiments, though.

“Welcome to the Royal Palace!” Glimmer interrupted her thoughts. “These are my father, King Micah, and my aunt, Castaspella, the Head Sorceress of Mystacore.”

If the Asgard had cat ears, they would have twitched with excitement, Catra was sure. They focused on Castaspella.

And wasn’t that interesting?

*****

Cultural Exchange Part 2

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, you're an alien. But you're human." The actor peered at Teal'c like he were in a zoo, in Jack O'Neill's impression.

Teal'c, of course, was stoically ignoring that. "I am a Jaffa. The false gods altered the human slaves they brought with them from Earth to create us as warriors for their armies," he explained.

"So, you're human." The actor nodded as if he were an actual scientist instead of having played such roles.

"I am a Jaffa."

"But you are descended from humans. Can you breed with humans?"

Jack pressed his lips together. That wasn't a question you asked a stranger you had just met. He made a quick note on his Bow-made tablet - that actor wouldn't be on the delegation; Jack would rather not find out how the princesses reacted to such rude questions.

"We are too different to produce viable offspring," Teal'c replied.

Jack thought his friend had way too much self-control as he finished his note.

"But can you have sex with humans? I mean, do you find humans attractive? Or do we smell alien to you?"

OK, that was enough!

"It depends," Teal'c replied in the same polite voice. "I do not find you attractive, but that is not because of your hygiene."

The actor stared at him with his mouth half-open while Jack and Teal'c left to head to the buffet. His friend also had a very dry sense of humour, Jack reminded himself.

"Sorry about that," Jack said in a low voice while picking up some sandwiches.

"It is better if such fools reveal themselves here instead of Etheria."

"Well, yes, but it's still not nice to deal with them." Jack glanced around. One singer was staring at them and keeping her distance. That wasn't a good sign, either.

"Compared to being shot at?" Teal'c raised his eyebrow.

"Well, at least you can shoot back there. Of course, we could…" Jack trailed off as he saw one of the more famous actors approaching them.

"Ah, General O'Neill!" The man smiled at him, then nodded at Teal'c. "I was wondering about something…"

Jack smiled politely. "Yes? We're here to answer questions."

"Will we have access to magical healing on Etheria?"

"They take good care of their guests, don't worry," Jack replied. "And they won't charge you for it, either."

"Ah."

"But unless you do something stupid, you won't have to fear getting hurt any more than you have on a promo tour on Earth," Jack added.

"And if we had a lingering issue?" The man took a sip from his drink.

Something in the way he said it made Jack want to frown. He didn't recall reading about any serious health issues when he checked the candidates' files - they had screened for that. "Are you currently sick?" They wouldn't send sick people to Etheria, either.

"No, no, just wondering if, say, Etheria has a magical cure for hangovers." The man chuckled at his own joke - if it was a joke.

The man's smile was open and friendly, but it raised Jack's hackles. Half the crowd here were actors - professional liars, in a way, he reminded himself. He shrugged. "I wouldn't know. I am usually on duty when I am on Etheria."

The man frowned for a moment, then leaned a bit closer with a toothier smile. "And even if you indulged, I doubt you'd suffer - you look like you're twenty years younger."

Oh, hell! Jack didn't look twenty years younger - but he felt like it. At least when he wasn't dealing with the current generation. But that effect of Adora's healing was classified. So, why did this damn civilian know about it? "You flatter me," he told the man. He had to get to the bottom of this - they couldn't afford leaks. It had been bad enough when people had rioted about magical healing. If they thought they could grow young again with magic…

"I'm just telling the truth."

Jack wanted to have the man dragged out by two guards and thrown into an interrogation room, but that would ruin the event at the least - and probably cause a lot of problems. Especially if the man blurted out what he knew to the rest of the room. "Sounds more like a rumour," he said.

"Sometimes rumours are truthful."

Wasn't that a line from a movie? "Well, I just have to look into a mirror to know it's not true."

"Age is not just your appearance."

“Don’t let Hollywood’s plastic surgeons hear that!” Jack quipped. “They’d lose all clients if that were true.”

The man smiled thinly. “Age is also how you move. How your body feels. Good actors - like me - know the difference between a young body and an old body moving.”

Yeah, the bastard definitely knew more than he should. “I wouldn’t know; I am no actor,” Jack said with a shrug.

“I find that hard to believe. Soldiering is hard on a body, isn’t it?”

Jack looked around. “Maybe we should talk about this later.”

The man’s smile made Jack want to smash his teeth in.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“So, the talent necessary to work magic as a sorceress is genetic - you and your brother both have inherited it, and King Micah passed it on to his daughter,” Freyr said.

“Yes,” Castaspella replied. She didn’t look annoyed at the question even though she had been telling their guests exactly that just a minute ago, Adora noted.

“And yet, all Gate Builders were able to use magic,” Freyr went on, “while this is not the case on Etheria, despite you being descendants of them.”

“We don’t count as First Ones,” Catra said. “With or without magic.”

“The genetic drift is probably too much,” Bow said. “It’s the same for the humans from Earth. Only some amongst them are recognised as First Ones - Ancients - by Alpha’s scanners.”

Thor frowned. Probably because he knew Alpha was working with Loki.

“You have not researched this?” Penegal sounded surprised. “Even though you have access to the Gate Builder’s research station?”

“Why would we care what kind of genes you must have to be considered a First One by an ancient laboratory?” Glimmer made a point of shrugging - quite Catra-like, Adora realised. “What matters aren’t your genes but your character.”

“But with a modicum of research, you could determine what makes someone a sorceress,” Penegal retorted. He almost sounded scandalised.

“We probably could, yes,” Micah said. “But why would we want to? We’re not going to breed people like animals.”

“Someone tell Anise that,” Catra muttered with a snort.

“Besides,” Castaspella said, “it’s usually passed on to your children.”

“You said usually.”

“Sometimes, children of a sorceress don’t have the talent. Sometimes, it skips a generation.” Castaspella shrugged. “It’s not like a princess’s lineage.”

“Have you examined those bloodlines?” Freyr asked.

“No,” Glimmer said. “If any princess wants to know more, they can have their genes analysed, but so far, none have asked.”

“Very curious,” Freyr said.

“And dangerous. If you are breeding out those talents, you might not realise it until it’s too late,” Penegal added.

Catra snorted again, and Adora didn't have to glance at her lover to know she was rolling her eyes.

Glimmer shook her head. "If that should happen, we have Alpha's databanks to go back to."

"Backed up," Bow added with a smile.

The Asgard frowned again. Were they disappointed that Etheria didn't have such records?

"And does Loki have access to this data?" Thor asked.

"No," Glimmer told him. "We won't let him use our genes to experiment."

"And yet, you let him use our genes," Thor shot back.

"His genes," Glimmer's smile grew a bit toothier. "He can experiment with his own genetics as much as he wants - they're his and his alone."

Uh-oh. Adora winced. They had planned to avoid that topic.

Bow smiled widely - and a bit forcedly, if you knew him. "But that's a different topic. You're here to experience our culture. So… how about we start with the palace? It's one of the oldest structures still used for their original purpose on Etheria, dating back to the founding of the kingdom." He gestured at the main corridor behind them. "And that leads directly to the throne room, where Glimmer holds court. Or Micah, if Glimmer is away."

The Asgard nodded - less reluctantly, or so it seemed, than Glimmer's own agreement.

Micah, though, beamed at them. "Oh, yes. However, it's a bit large for daily business, so that's usually done in our offices - unless we want to make a point.

They led the Asgard through the wide corridor, but their guests didn't look impressed. They hadn't been impressed by anything at all so far, in Adora's impression. Even though the palace was one of the most beautiful buildings she had ever seen.

Of course, she might be a bit biased since she was living here, and she would never tell the other princesses that she thought Glimmer's palace was the best.

They reached the throne room. Glimmer must have noticed the Asgard's lack of a reaction as well since she opened the doors herself with a flourish. "We've gathered a delegation of Etherian's best scholars and artists and most of the members of the Princess Alliance."

The Throne room held a decent crowd. Partially because they had decided to recruit for both cultural exchanges together, Adora knew, but even so, now that the Asgard had arrived, the smiles and curious looks of the people in the room seemed genuine. At least to Adora.

George and Lance, standing in the front row next to the princesses, certainly were enthusiastic. Mainly because the Asgards were contemporaries of the First Ones, but it still counted. Or should.

As Glimmer started introducing the various people to the Asgard, who were quickly surrounded by the crowd, Adora let herself relax. Things were looking up.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Where did he get classified information? And who is backing him? I need answers, folks!"

The General was furious. Samantha Carter could see that in his tight expression. The clipped sentences confirmed it. He wasn't

cracking dark jokes, but that was usually a mixed sign. And he wasn't pacing in his office.

"Do you really think this is a plot, Jack?" Daniel asked. "He could just have heard a rumour and decided he wanted this for himself as well."

"Would a mere actor really challenge the military leadership like that without someone more powerful backing him?" Sha're asked.

Sam pressed her lips together for a moment. Daniel's wife had not yet fully acclimated to Earth society or she wouldn't ask that question.

"In a heartbeat," the General told her. "Those actors are all full of themselves - they think they're above everyone!"

"Not everyone, Jack!" Daniel objected. "But a fair amount of them do have a bit overblown egos, yes." He frowned. "One of them tried to argue with my thesis based on an article he read in the *Rolling Stone*. Not even Popular Science!"

Sam had to smile at her friend's outraged expression. She was pretty sure she knew which actor had done that - one had been asking her quite the questions, but the man had at least not tried to argue physics with her.

"See?" The General nodded sharply.

Sha're didn't look convinced, though. "You also impressed upon them that they would be under your authority during this mission, and they didn't disagree."

"Indeed." Teal'c nodded slowly.

"That's because they know we won't let them go to Etheria if they don't play nice," the General said. "But once they're there? Or back? Some of them will already be talking to a ghostwriter for their 'The Truth about Etheria' book."

“But that’s why you had this meeting - to weed out those untrustworthy,” Sha’re pointed out.

“Yes. But we won’t get all of them. At least one will have to find out the hard way that we’re not joking.” The General shook his head. “But that’s not as serious as this. We’re dealing with a leak here!” He turned to her. “Have you checked our data security?”

“I would need a thorough evaluation of the entire data traffic to find proof of illegitimate access,” Sam explained. “And that wouldn’t detect someone with the necessary clearance showing his screen to someone else - or just telling someone after work.” Of course, if they had been sloppy, one could check if the time of access of the classified data correlated with a visitor in that office, but she doubted that anyone with the clearance for his would be that careless.

The General frowned at that, and Sam suppressed the slight guilt she felt for disappointing him. It wasn’t her fault that reality worked that way.

“So, we need to start with Mr Self-Important and work backwards.” He nodded. “But that will take a while. And we have to deal with the bastard soon.”

“He has shown he knows classified information,” Sha’re said. “Can’t you imprison him?” She looked at Daniel. “This seems to be a case of this ‘national security’ excuse you mentioned.”

Daniel winced a little, but the General chuckled. “I wish! But he’s very prominent and has given himself enough cover, so a decent lawyer would demolish us if we locked him up. And no, we can’t just vanish him either - even if we wanted to, and I am sure the NID would love to, and even if we managed to fool the press and the cops, the Etherians would ask questions. The bastard is really popular on their planet, or so it seems.”

“Well, he’s the lead of a very successful TV show,” Daniel pointed out. “And he plays a very nice and charming character. He’s not at

all like his character, of course, but…" He shrugged.

"Yeah, yeah. Maybe we can vanish him after the Etherians discover what he's like, but that won't help us now."

"What does he want?" Sha're asked.

"Access to magical healing," Sam replied.

"If he is as well-liked as you say on Etheria, couldn't he just ask for healing during his visit?"

"He could. But he'll discover that the magical treatment he might receive on Etheria won't duplicate She-Ra's healing," Sam explained.

"And then he'll want the real thing," the General finished. "And I don't like giving in to this kind of underhanded pressure. If you let them get away with this, they'll try to get more next time. So, we need to shut him down - and plug that leak."

Sam suppressed a sigh. He was right, anyway. "I'll look into his communications, sir." That was illegal, but between her advanced technology and some help from Entrapta, it was unlikely that she would be caught. And even if she did, that kind of thing could be swept under the rug, given the circumstances.

And if it couldn't, she could move to Etheria and do science with less paperwork and more freedom, a small voice in the back of her head whispered.

She ignored it.

"Good!" The General nodded. "And I'll need everyone else on the meeting with the bastard. Anything, any hint, any insight."

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“So, you actually met the First Ones - I mean, the Ancients, oh, you call them the Gate Builders, right?”

Catra had to give credit to the Asgard - they didn’t react much to Lance getting so close in their face, even the French would remind him to respect personal space. On the other hand, the man’s enthusiasm and cheer were obvious, and the Asgard might like that. Especially after the somewhat lukewarm reception by most of the artists in the room - they didn’t think much of Asgard epics and music, although they were very polite about it. And most of the princesses weren’t much better, either - though Scorpia and Perfuma were talking animatedly with Penegal right now at the buffet.

“Dear…” George put his hand on Lance’s arm with a wry smile.

“Oh, I’m really sorry!” Lance bowed his head - no, his entire upper body - in apology. “The First Ones are a passion of ours, and when I heard that we would be meeting people who had actually met them…” He sighed.

Adora’s a First One, too. Catra didn’t say that, of course. They could use any honest enthusiasm for this visit. And it was kind of interesting to see where Bow got some of his mannerisms from. He was a bit of a mix of his two dads.

“We did not meet the Gate Builders at their peak, but we do remember them, yes,” Thor said. “Though not the ones who did build the research base here, I don’t think so.”

Yeah, Catra didn’t think the First Ones would have ignored the Asgard if they had known them during their war with the Horde - they should have known about the connection between the Horde and the Asgard once they had analysed a clone’s genes. Which they had - Alpha had mentioned bioweapon research. Although… “Well, they were busy building an Empire of their own and colonising planets, so they might have hidden from you as well.”

Thor frowned at that. Adora as well, of course - even if it wasn't her fault.

"That might have influenced them to keep hidden, though it seems a bit odd that they didn't reach out to us once they started losing the war against Horde Prime," the Asgard commented.

Catra shrugged. "They might have been too proud to ask for help."

"Or they feared your reaction," Glimmer added.

"But this meeting is not about Horde Prime but about a cultural exchange between Etheria and the Asgard!" Adora cut in with a wide and forced smile.

Right. No reminding, even indirectly, the Asgard of their unwanted grandkids.

"Yes!" Lance nodded enthusiastically. Very enthusiastically - Bow was wincing, Catra noted with a smirk. "And the First Ones are a very important part of Etherian culture - quite natural, of course, since they were responsible for creating so many of our ancestors."

"And are our ancestors," George added.

"Yes, yes, of course." Lance nodded again. "Their structures might lie in ruins, but their influence remains - although often in a subtle way."

"And how strong is this influence?" Freyr asked.

"That varies from kingdom to kingdom," Lance replied. "Different princesses took different aspects of the First One's culture, from what we can tell - though we are still researching this complex topic."

"And how much of their influence remains in Bright Moon?" Freyr asked, tilting his head a bit.

“Bright Moon’s a special case since its founder, Queen Angella, was a direct, ah, result of the First One’s genetic engineering program on Alpha and ruled the kingdom for so long. And yet, she never mentioned meeting the First Ones. So, we don’t know her views of the First Ones culture. But Bright Moon doesn’t share many aspects of known First Ones culture,” Lance said.

“We didn’t even know about the Stargate network,” Glimmer added. “Mum would have told us that if she had known.”

Adora nodded at that. “And she would have told me more about She-Ra if she had met Mara - my predecessor, and also a First One,” she explained.

“Ah.” Freyr nodded.

“And yet, you control the research base they left,” Thor said.

“Yes, because we have a claim on the Moons of Enchantment,” Glimmer replied a little testily.

“Even though until recently, you had no means to reach them?” Freyr looked curious.

“Yes.” Glimmer looked as if she dared him to question her claim.

Which could be seen as a bit questionable from a certain point of view, Catra had to admit. Not that she cared about it - as long as Adora was fine with it, it was OK.

“This claim could be influenced by Queen Angella’s history with the First Ones,” Lance speculated. “We just don’t know enough about her - or the First Ones. It was such a boon when Bow introduced Adora to us. We were not even able to read their language before she translated it for us!”

Adora blushed a little.

“That’s why I have this tattoo,” George said, pulling his left sleeve back. “I thought it meant ‘love’,” he explained with a wry

expression.

"It means 'lunch', I believe," Freyr said.

"Yes, it does." Adora looked embarrassed, and Catra snickered with everyone else at George's expense - he took it good-naturedly.

Didn't they have a saying on Earth? That love went through your stomach or something?

"So, does your view of what are safe experiments contain some of the Gate Builder's influence?" Thor asked, and everyone grew serious again. Well, everyone who was paying attention and not raiding the buffet, like most of the others in the Throne Room were doing.

"No, they stem from our experience with dangerous experiments," Glimmer told him. "We're very familiar with such - Etheria was almost destroyed because of a First One project."

"Our culture is very safety-conscious," Adora said - with a smile that wouldn't have fooled Emily.

Catra sighed. Her love was trying way too hard.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, any new intel?" Jack O'Neill asked a last time as he checked his computer for any possible notices.

"I'm sorry, sir, but I haven't been able to find any electronic leak so far."

"Sorry, Jack, celebrities aren't exactly my, ah, speciality. I've been going over the available material, but it's a bit limited - tabloids

rarely report what people celebrities talk to at parties and mixers. Unless it's about a new affair."

"Are you sure that some of this isn't deliberate disinformation, my love?."

Great. He had to go into that meeting with the bastard without intel to back him up. He didn't like that at all, but it wasn't the fault of his team. Or would that be friends now? They weren't exactly his team any more, not formally.

He pushed that thought, and also the small voice in the back of his mind that wanted to point out what not being in the same chain of command would mean, away and nodded. "It was always a slim chance," he said.

"Yes, sir." Carter pressed her lips together as she nodded, and Jack felt a bit guilty - she would still feel as if she had failed him, even though it wasn't her fault at all; not even Carter could work miracles all the time.

But the bastard was waiting, and short of an actual crisis, Jack couldn't let him wait any longer - the arrogant actor had the vibe of someone who'd take petty revenge no matter the cost if he felt slighted, and they had to assume he had contacts in the Alliance. "Alright, let's see what exactly the bastard wants. Did anyone start a betting pool?"

Daniel chuckled at that, and even Carter smiled a little. Sha're looked confused, but Daniel would explain.

Jack left his office and went to the meeting room where the blackmailing bastard was waiting.

"Sorry for the wait," he said as he entered the room. "But we're in the middle of a war, you know."

"I heard war was ninety-five per cent waiting and five per cent action," the actor replied before taking a sip from his soda. He didn't get up from his seat at the table, of course.

“It’s mostly training, actually,” Jack told him as he sat down opposite the bastard. “For the soldiers, anyway. Analysts and staff rarely have to wait a lot - we’re buried in work.”

The man shrugged, obviously not caring about any soldier or other people actually doing their thing to defend Earth. Or that was what he wanted Jack to think - he was a skilled actor, after all, Jack reminded himself. He couldn’t trust anything the man said or did.

Of course, his team was watching over the cameras, and he was wearing a bud in his ear in case they found something, but Jack didn’t expect them to have more success at analysing the actor.

“So… what do you want?” Jack asked, leaning forward and putting his elbows on the table.

He couldn’t tell If his direct question rattled the bastard. The man smiled at him. “Direct and to the point - just as your reputation claims!”

Flattery - or had someone told him about Jack as well? Anyone who knew Jack knew he could be sneaky when he wanted to. Although most would also know that but for the Alliance with Etheria, Jack wouldn’t have gotten his current rank - he had made too many enemies, and saving Earth against orders could only make up for so much in the shark pool of staff politics. But this might be an attempt at deception, to make him underestimate the man’s knowledge. So Jack shrugged. “I have to. So much to do, and a day only has so many hours, so why waste it on chitchat?”

The actor chuckled. “Oh, don’t I know it! Whenever I am on a set, it’s always like that!”

Now, that was a lie - Daniel had discovered and confirmed that the man wasn’t exactly the most stressed actor. He did his scenes and then fucked off to his trailer - or home - at the first opportunity. Sometimes with a starlet. The last thing he did was

working too much. But Jack nodded as if he believed him. "So, let's not beat around the bush. What do you want?"

The man nodded. "I'm not getting any younger, and there's no cure for age. Or there wasn't until magic appeared."

Ah. So, it seemed that the man wasn't hiding some serious illness from his employers and the military doctors. He simply wanted to be twenty again - as he had hinted at during their first meeting. And without makeup, he looked his age, Jack noticed.

"The Etherians didn't find a fountain of Eternal Youth either," Jack told him. "Magic can't do everything."

The man snorted. "That's a nice story - good to keep the masses from realising what they can do - but I know better." He leaned forward as well. "*You've got the body of a twenty-year-old*."

Jack's classified medical report actually said 'peak health for a man his age' and 'healthy as a twenty-year-old', but this was too close to be a mere guess. The man wouldn't have gotten this from analysing She-Ra's mass-healing in India. Someone had read Jack's medical files and revealed it to a damn actor. And once Jack found out who had done it, he would nail the bastard to the wall!

But while this was bad enough, anyone who could get his medical file could also access other classified data. Even if they were limited to medical data, that was a lot. This was about as bad as Jack had feared. But it still wasn't solid enough to arrest the bastard.

He smiled, showing his teeth, and didn't try to hide his disdain. "And you want that."

The other man nodded, smiling without any shame. "Yes. Who wouldn't? Eternal youth has been a dream of humanity since forever," he added. "If this got out, it would make the First Contact riots like a kindergarten spat over the last slice of birthday cake."

"I've heard worse rumours about what magic can do," Jack replied.

"Rumours, yes. But this is the truth." The man flashed his teeth at Jack. "It can be proven."

And that was the threat. "If someone slipped, you mean."

"Or something happened to me." The man shrugged. "You have a certain reputation."

Jack nodded - and hid his grim satisfaction. The number of people who had access to his medical data and his black ops past was far smaller than those who had access to either but not both. Carter was probably already running an analysis. And Jack had a list of people who he had clashed with during his career in that field.

But that would take time. So, for now, he had to play along. But not too eagerly. "If such a magical cure for ageing existed, it would be in the hands of the Etherians."

"In the hands of She-Ra, who is your close friend - so close, she made you a general." The actor shook his head. "She'd do you a small favour like this without question."

The leak definitely was someone with a grudge against Jack, then. And either a fellow general - or someone who didn't get promoted as fast.

Good.

"It's not exactly a small favour, though…" Jack continued the act, thinking about how he would enjoy bringing down both this bastard and the leaker.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 2nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and that was the first All-Princess Ball - which ended the Age of War. Well, Etheria still saw wars, but never again on the scale of that epoch until the Horde War, which dwarfed every other conflict. The All-Princess Ball…"

"Or Princess Prom."

Adora wasn't sure if Glimmer was being helpful or not, but Lance nodded at her before he smoothly continued: "...also known as Princess Prom - remains the most prestigious and most important diplomatic event of Etheria, where all Princesses, no matter if they rule a kingdom or not, are allowed entry, with strict neutrality guaranteed by their host. This tradition was upheld over centuries, even during the Horde War. In fact, except for a violent incident between the then-rulers of Plumeria and the Kingdom of Snows over a shared lover, which was, by all accounts, a private affair and only escalated to a conflict between the realms after the near-strangling respectively freezing of the involved princesses, the Horde was the only power ever to break the ancient rules of hospitality of the event."

"It seemed a good idea at the time," Catra commented with a shrug.

"You broke centuries of tradition during?" Freyr asked. He seemed more concerned about that than the fact that Catra had been a Force Captain in the Horde at the time.

"I'm not a princess, so technically, it was Scorpia, but I gave the order, yes." Catra met the Asgard's eyes.

"And we've all moved past that," Adora cut in. "The Horde War is over, and we're all friends now."

"Try telling Frosta that," Catra muttered under her breath, but the Asgard nodded.

"This event seems to have influenced your diplomatic traditions - namely, that you are willing to forge alliances with former enemies," Freyr commented.

“Yes,” Lance said. “Although it was but one element of several, being able to meet other princesses in a neutral setting and socialise with them would have helped foster a culture of limited conflict where peace didn’t require the complete defeat of the enemy.”

“And yet, the Horde War ended with the complete defeat of Horde Prime.”

Thor sounded a tad smug. At least, that was Adora’s impression.

“Well…” Bow spoke up. “It depends if you consider the Horde War one conflict or two. There are arguments for both views. But even so, the only one who suffered total defeat was Horde Prime - the Clones and the Horde Soldiers were welcomed into the Princess Alliance even if they didn’t defect during the conflict.”

That was, perhaps, a bit generous. Technically correct, since the Horde Soldiers were pretty much all living in the reformed Scorpion Kingdom, which was a member of the Princess Alliance, but not many other kingdoms except for Plumeria had welcomed them within their borders. And the Clones pretty much stuck to their own. Except for Third Fleet’s missionaries, of course.

“But do you expect to treat the Goa’uld the same?” Freyr asked. “Offer them the chance to change sides and retain their positions?”

“If they change, yes,” Adora said. “They cannot keep slaves or oppress anyone. And they can’t take unwilling hosts. And they have to be honest.” Hadn’t they told the Asgard that before?

“And, of course, if they break their word, we aren’t bound to ours any more either,” Glimmer added, showing her teeth. “And the same goes for Loki.”

“Ah.” Freyr nodded.

“We’re not naive,” Glimmer told him. “But we give people a chance to change.”

“Laudable,” Thor said. “And yet, you ignore that Loki has failed to change despite having had many such chances.”

“It’s never too late to change,” Adora said.

“That seems to contradict Queen Glimmer’s claim,” Freyr pointed out.

“It doesn’t.” Catra was tense - her ears were laid back a little, and her tail twitched a lot - and she had crossed her arms over her chest - as she narrowed her eyes at him. “You can give people more chances if you can keep them from being a danger to you and others.”

“And if you can’t?” Thor asked.

“Then you do what you can to neutralise them as a threat.”

“But we’re talking politics again,” Adora stepped in. “We’re here to show our culture and traditions.”

“The point of this visit is to build trust,” Thor retorted. “And the biggest issue is my brother. And his plan to alter the very heart of our culture.”

She pressed her lips together. Did he have to insist on this?

“You’ve heard about our traditions. Some of them,” Glimmer said. “You know how they came to be,” she added with a nod and a smile at Lance and George. “But we’re a long way from finished. There are many kingdoms with their own cultures and traditions, even if we limit this visit to the Alliance.”

“But you didn’t come here for Etherian traditions anyway, did you?” Catra spoke. “You came here for Etherian *magic*.”

Adora frowned. What was Catra saying? The Asgard looked… not guilty, but not surprised either, she noticed.

“It is unique to Etheria,” Freyr said.

Penegal nodded. “We never used magitech much, lacking the ability to use magic, so we developed our technology without it, but the Gate Builders relied on it.”

“Are you looking for a magic cure for your problems?” Bow asked, then blushed and glanced around. “Sorry.”

Catra snickered, and Glimmer groaned, but Adora didn’t think it was bad. They were surrounded by friends. And except for Bow’s dads, the other guests didn’t seem to be paying them much attention, anyway.

“We don’t know if this is a feasible option,” Freyr said.

“In other words: Yes, you are.” Catra smirked.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 3rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

“You didn’t pull an all-nighter, did you, Carter?”

Samantha Carter suppressed a frown at the General’s question. He couldn’t know from seeing her that she had worked through the night on this - she had checked in the mirror before this meeting. And she had had a nap before this. She had done worse before, anyway. And before She-Ra had healed her during the mission on Saqqara. “I finished before bedtime, sir,” she replied, a little sharper than usual. It was true, anyway - depending on which day you were talking about. And she’d had to do this - it was important. For the Alliance and for the General.

He didn’t seem to believe her, but he didn’t press her on this either. She had expected that, of course.

As she took her seat at the table, Daniel leaned over and whispered. “You did, didn’t you?”

She rolled her eyes at him in return and took a sip from the coffee he handed her. Good.

"So!" The General sat down as well. "Now, let's see what we can do about our blackmailing problem. You've said you had something for me, Carter."

"Yes, sir." Sam switched her laptop on - this kind of thing was best done off the main computer system. "I've correlated the data Daniel and Sha're gathered through the news and the known schedules of the various people with access to our medical files." Which was technically illegal, but this wasn't a criminal investigation. And she had access to the databanks for technical reasons, so one could argue the legality of this.

"Our suspects." The General nodded.

"Yes, sir." She opened the charts she had prepared, her laptop's holoprojector displaying them floating above the table. "There's no direct correlation between them, and their itineraries - their offical ones; I haven't had access to private ones - don't match up."

"I sense a 'but' coming." The General grinned.

"Yes, sir. There are several flights of his private jet logged between Los Angeles and Washington D.C. that do not match up with any publicly known events of our… main suspect."

"I think, seeing as he admitted to blackmailing us, we can call the bastard 'culprit,' Carter."

"And those dates line up with the vacation days logged by General Smith." A four-star general. Short of the leak being a member of the Alliance High Command, this was the worst case situation. "Not all of them, but three in the time span of five years," Sam finished, highlighting the six flights. "None of them during regular holidays."

"And given how difficult it is to get leave even during major holidays as a general, as I found out…" The General bared his teeth. "That would be quite a coincidence."

"It's not proof, though," Daniel pointed out.

"It's proof enough," Sha're disagreed.

"Not for a court, my love. Or to arrest anyone."

"But it's proof enough to, ah, take a closer look at what my dear fellow general has been doing in Hollywood. It wasn't negotiating Air Force support for 'Top Gun 2 - The Air Force Strikes Back', that's for sure."

"They're making a sequel?" Daniel blinked. "And I thought Top Gun was about the Navy…?"

"That's 'No, they aren't', and 'Exactly', Daniel." The General grinned. "Which is my point. We've got our suspect. Now we just need to find enough proof to nail him."

Sam nodded. Enough proof to deal with the man. Not necessarily enough to charge him. "We should inform the Etherians, sir."

He frowned at her. "The idea is to keep this under wraps until we've dealt with it, Carter."

"They have resources that would help with this," she pointed out. And they had diplomatic immunity.

"Adora also can't act worth a damn, and Glimmer's got a temper," he objected. "We'd be blowing this wide open if we involve them. Can you imagine them playing nice with Smith while they're in a meeting that's already annoying?"

"I wasn't thinking about Adora and Glimmer, sir," she explained. "I was thinking about Catra. And Melog."

"Ah!" He smiled widely. "Yeah, that's different."

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Cultural Exchange Part 3

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 3rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and we thought you could help us deal with this. From the Etherian side, so to speak."

"So, you've got a scumbag trying to blackmail you into Adora healing him, and you want me to help you without making Glimmer lose her temper or Adora trying to act innocent?" Catra cocked her head to the side as she looked at Sam and Daniel.

"Err, yes." Daniel blushed a little. Had he really expected she wouldn't figure out why they were coming to her with this instead of to Adora - the Supreme Commander of the Alliance - or Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon and member of the Alliance Command Council or whatever they called it this week? Catra didn't even have a formal rank in the Alliance.

"Well, that was a good decision." Catra nodded in approval. Judging by the faint smile on Sam's face, that had been her idea, then. "But what do you want done about him?"

"We're working on uncovering the leak," Sam explained.

"And you can't just arrest the guy and interrogate him until he spills his source because that's illegal on Earth, right?" Catra shook her head. Sometimes, she wondered how Earth countries could function with all that red tape. On the other hand, if someone had been able to restrict her more reckless decisions, back in the Horde… Bah. That was the past.

"Yes." Sha're sighed a little as she nodded.

"Err, there are good reasons for that," Daniel said.

"I know, my love, but they are also inconvenient at a time like this."

Catra could agree with that. “Well, I guess we can’t really have him disappear on Etheria, either.”

Daniel gasped a little. “No, we can’t!”

Catra had been joking, anyway. Mostly. A little trip, and he could become ‘lost’ in the Whispering Woods. If he was as over-confident as some of his roles, no one would question that he wanted to brave the woods alone. But people would wonder why he had been allowed to enter the woods alone and question the competency of the Princess Alliance. Or suspect foul play - Earth media were all about such plots, and from what Catra had learned about Earth's history, their governments were worse. But that wasn’t the point here, anyway.

“We just need you to ensure he doesn’t cause any trouble,” Sam said, “while we handle the Earth part of this.”

Catra nodded. “Especially if he wants to cause trouble. Which he would if he suspects something.”

“We’re hoping he won’t,” Sam said.

“That’s why you came to me.” Catra nodded. Slowly. And took a deep breath. They meant well. They just hadn’t thought it through. They hadn’t considered how this would look from another point of view. Namely, hers. “Yeah, that’s a solid plan. Simple goal, clear reason. There’s only one problem with it.”

“Oh?” Daniel looked surprised. Sam’s eyes widened as well. And Sha’re was frowning.

“You want me to lie to my friends. To Adora.” Her love.

“Ah.” Daniel blinked. “Oh.”

Sam winced.

And Sha’re glanced at Daniel, then met Catra’s eyes.

“That’s…” Daniel started to say, but Sha’re interrupted him. “We’re sorry. We should have realised what we were asking of you, but we didn’t.” She bowed her head for a moment.

Catra let her breath out. “Yeah, it’s…” It wasn’t OK, but it hadn’t been deliberate. “I understand your line of thinking.” But to suggest she should betray Adora, hurt her like that… She clenched her teeth at the thought. Never again. She’d rather die.

All three winced at that, and Catra felt a pang of guilt. They still had a pretty serious problem to solve, and their reasons for suggesting to keep this from Adora - and Glimmer, and the others - were not entirely stupid. What Catra had heard of the mission to the Enchanted Grotto didn’t fill her with much confidence in the Princess Alliance’s capability to conduct undercover operations.

Sighing once more, she said: “So, we’ll have to plan this carefully - with the others. And if Her Sparkliness blows her top, I’m not going to intervene.”

“That’s fair,” Sha’re said. The other two grimaced.

“Let’s hope the Asgard haven’t frustrated Glimmer too much today,” Catra said as she got up.

“Oh? Are things not going well?” Daniel asked, pushing his glasses up his nose.

“They haven’t threatened war yet,” Catra told him. “But they have very different views, and, apparently, they think as little of our art and stuff as we think of theirs.” Which was to be expected if the Asgard enjoyed the things Loki had shown them.

“Oh.” Daniel frowned for a moment. “Have you tried to show them artwork comparable to the Norse culture’s works? They influenced that culture, after all, and so they might enjoy similar art.”

Catra snorted. “Yes. But the Asgard apparently thought sea shanties were parodies of their epics.” To be fair, Sea Hawk singing them probably hadn’t helped. The man had a good voice,

but he was just too passionate about it. And turning every second shanty into a love song for Mermista hadn't helped.

Daniel winced again. "And what about rune carvings?"

Catra sighed once more. "Castaspella said most Etherian runes were related to magic and that it wasn't a good idea to try out new runes without proper precautions. The Asgard disagreed. Last I heard, they were still 'discussing' things when you called for me."

"Ah. Well, we didn't hear any explosions on the way in…"

Catra laughed at the weak joke. "Anyway, let's go and see if we can get Adora and Glimmer. If all goes well, they'll probably be happy to be called away."

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 3rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

General Smith had been up to no good. Jack O'Neill was sure of that. And serious no-good stuff, not just the usual things a four-star general did to get promoted if they hadn't saved the world from evil alien body-snatching snakes a few times and were friends with magical princesses who had a huge fleet of spaceships with big honking guns.

Jack leaned back in his seat and dropped the report he had been trying to read on his desk.

The problem was finding enough proof of said no-good stuff. Well, that was one problem. The other problem was finding out what Smith wanted. Why would a four-star general send a bloody Hollywood actor to blackmail Jack? It didn't make much sense. Smith didn't have a reputation for gossiping or drinking, so while it wasn't impossible that he had let slip something classified to a civilian friend at a mixer, it was very unlikely. Smith also wasn't stupid - he would know that Jack wouldn't let some arrogant actor

push him around. And he would be aware that, especially now that the United States finally were officially at war, said arrogant actor could end up arrested in a heartbeat.

It wouldn't stick, though. The bastard had used a cover story that was bullshit but just plausible enough to get out of prison as soon as a decent lawyer was brought in. Or, if that didn't work fast enough, the press got a story about the evil Alliance trying to send an actor who had found out too much to a gulag. Which the public would take as proof that the Alliance was keeping magic that made you young again for themselves.

And that would be a catastrophe. Everyone with money and influence would try to get this, and most of them would not baulk at anything to be young again. Even worse, those without influence or money would riot. The First Contact riots had been bad enough, but this would put the worst anti-magic riots in the Middle East to shame. And if the Russians and the Chinese leaders decided that they wanted access to this…

The Alliance would be hard-pressed to handle all of this without the war against the snakes and the current issues with the Asgard.

Was that what Smith was counting on? That Jack would rather ask Adora to heal a puffed-up actor than risk such a catastrophe? But Smith would also know that Jack wouldn't let this go. And neither would the princesses. Was Smith trusting the threat of revealing the healing effects to keep him safe from retaliation? That would be short-sighted. And stupid. Such a threat would have to be neutralised. Not to mention that Jack didn't think the idiot actor would be able to keep quiet once people noticed. No, that scumbag would tell his trusted friends - or people he wanted to impress or get favours off. Or the latest starlet in his bed.

And even if Smith were stupid enough to trust such a scheme, what was he getting out of this? Jack couldn't see how this whole thing benefitted Smith. If they gave in to the blackmail to keep the secret, then that would mean the odds of anyone else getting

Adora's healing would be even lower. If Smith wanted to have a young body again, it would have been better to do the blackmail directly. Hell, if he skipped the blackmail and just asked Adora directly, maybe added some sob story about being in pain, she might have healed him anyway.

So, what was Smith's goal? Was he being blackmailed by someone? Had he had some affair with a starlet, courtesy of his 'friend', and now it turned out that his friend had some demands to keep it a secret from Smith's wife? But would Smith go that far? Not for an affair, Jack thought. That sort of stuff still damaged your career, but they were at war now, which meant standards were looser - and Jack wasn't going to dwell on what might mean with regards to other rules that he wouldn't break anyway - and Smith was a decent officer and would know similar secrets of politicians and fellow officers. Enough to keep his post, though it might cost him a future promotion.

So, if Smith was being blackmailed, it had to be something more serious. And it would have a Hollywood connection. Drugs? They regularly tested for that - when you had to check for snake possession or weird alien stuff, scanning for drugs at the same time was just routine. So, if Smith had a secret, it had to be something more serious.

Which brought Jack back to his main problem: Finding out what Smith was hiding. And who was helping the bastard. Maybe he should do some field work himself, check out the man's home… No. He snorted at his own foolishness. If he got caught breaking into Smith's house, not even Adora's influence could save him from getting cashiered or worse. He had made too many enemies to escape such a blunder, both in politics and the general staff. Too many would be happy to see him gone.

He blinked.

Maybe that was Smith's goal.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 3rd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and so we would like you to act as if nothing is wrong while we investigate further."

Adora took a deep breath after Sam finished her explanation. So, in the middle of the Asgard visit, they were facing another crisis. This was….

"We've got a scumbag trying to blackmail the Alliance, and we're supposed to do nothing about it?" Glimmer blurted out as she stood, both palms pressed on the table.

…infuriating, yes. "We can't just do nothing," she agreed with her friend, looking at Daniel, Sha're and Sam.

"We're not expecting you to do nothing," Daniel told her - wincing a little. "But until we know what's going on, we don't want to let the, ah, suspects, get spooked - we want them to think their plan is working."

"And Melog and I are going to help find out what's behind this blackmail," Catra added.

Melog glowed briefly in a smattering of colours.

Right. Sam had mentioned that as well. Adora nodded.

"Why you?" Glimmer asked with narrowed eyes.

Catra grinned. "Because we're unlikely to lose our temper and blow up this operation."

Adora winced, already knowing Glimemr wouldn't like that. Especially not when she was already angry.

"Says the woman whose mood can be spotted on Melog!" Glimmer spat, as expected.

Melog did flicker red for a moment before switching back, Adora noticed.

"Not too many people know that," Catra said. She cocked her head to the side, listening to her friend. "And Melog won't be visible often."

Adora bit her lower lip. That was one potential problem handled. "But if you leave, the Asgard will wonder why," she added before Glimmer could say something else to continue the argument.

Catra shrugged. "So? Let them. We're fighting a war. They can't expect us to focus everything on them."

"Well, they could - we don't know much about their culture and customs," Daniel pointed out. "But they have to be aware that both Etheira and Earth have different customs."

"If they want to take offence, they will take offence anyway," Sha're added. "Whether at this or at any other excuse."

That would ruin the entire plan of earning their trust. But if they were not willing to be open-minded, then the plan had been doomed from the start. Still… Adora shook her head. One problem at a time, she reminded herself of the old lesson from cadet training. If she tried to do everything at once, she wouldn't succeed at anything. "So… you'll go to Earth for a while?" she asked Catra.

Her lover shrugged. "I can return through the Stargate anytime I want. But we'll probably need some time to find out what's behind this."

So, they would be separated for a time. Again. Alone. Adora briefly pressed her lips together. She was better than that. And Catra and Melog were needed on Earth, less so on Etheria right now, while Adora had to be here to handle the Asgard's visit. They could do this. It wouldn't be too long, anyway. Either they would find the culprit quickly, or the Asgard visit would end, and Adora would spend more time on Earth in the Alliance Headquarters. At

least until the cultural exchange with Earth started. Though if Adora was on Earth, then that would be a good reason not to heal that traitorous actor…

She nodded. “Alright. Anything else?”

Glimmer frowned at her. Had she expected Adora to veto this plan? What was the alternative? Risk having everyone on Earth think she could turn back old age? It was bad enough that so many wanted her to heal them, they were willing to riot. Adora suppressed a shudder when she remembered Paris.

“I can’t believe they’d do that,” Bow spoke up. “I love that show!”

“They’re an actor,” Cara told him with a scoff. “They are just playing a role. You can’t trust them.”

Was she talking about all actors or this one in particular? Or was she talking about Double Trouble? The spy’s actions hadn’t really left a good impression on, well, anyone, but Catra carried a particular grudge. Adora could understand it, of course.

She wished things were different, though. It was too bad that they couldn’t trust Double Trouble. They would be perfect for such a mission. But letting them loose on Earth? That would be a disaster. If they were lucky, Double Trouble would finish the job before going off on their own to cause chaos, but they wouldn’t be able to resist stirring up trouble.

And they wouldn’t care that Etheria was in the middle of a war or that the situation on Earth could break out in riots or worse with just a slight provocation.

“Well, they’re a good actor,” Bow defended himself.

“But not a good person,” Adora said.

“As far as we know,” Daniel cautioned.

Even Sha’re rolled her eyes at him at that, Adora saw.

He flushed a little. “I am just pointing out that we don’t know what is behind this yet. We shouldn’t judge people without all the information.”

He was right about that, but things were not looking good for the man, in Adora’s opinion.

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Above the Pentagon, Washington D.C., United States of America, December 3rd, 1999

“So, you have checked the ‘suspect’s’ offices in the Alliance headquarters already, and found nothing suspect? That’s suspicious.”

Samantha Carter nodded at Catra’s question and ignored the wording. If her friend wanted to make fun of the correct terms for an investigation, then that was fine as long as it didn’t hinder the investigation. “He has not been working in Brussels for long, and he seems not to have made many friends amongst the general staff of the other Alliance members.” Something unfortunately quite common for many American officers, as Sam had also found out. It apparently wasn’t just because the Stargate had been kept a secret from the other countries, either - many NATO members had long memories. But that was a problem for another day.

“Yeah. He certainly has no friends in our ranks. Acquaintances yes - he did good work on the PZ-921 offensive - but he wasn’t really friendly. Juliet thought he might have issues with magic.” Catra shrugged and shifted in the copilot seat of the General’s stealth shuttle.

Or women, Sam thought with a slight frown. From what information she had gathered, General Smith had never shown open misogyny - he wouldn’t have kept his position, much less have been integrated into the Alliance command structure if he had - but he hadn’t spoken up for female officers either. Or had had any trouble with the more open misogynist officers in the

force. Of course, he might just have had issues with General Juliet's style. The commander of Bright Moon's forces liked to wear her armour when on duty. Which included a cape.

But that was irrelevant right now. They were not investigating Smith's views on women but his potential crimes. "If he is doing anything illegal, it's unlikely he'll do it in his office."

"Which you have bugged already." Her friend grinned.

"Appropriate measures have been taken," Sam confirmed. "We're tracking his electronic communication as well." Including all cell phones used at his home, in case he was using burner phones.

"And you think it won't be enough, or we wouldn't be here." Catra nodded at Melog, who was sitting on the floor next to her seat.

"We haven't found any electronic trace of General Smith being in contact with our primary suspect. So, it was likely done face to face or through an intermediary."

"Like we do things on Etheria." Catra flashed her fangs, and her tail swished, then she turned to frown at Melog. "That was different! That was just regular communication during the war."

A moment later, she frowned again. "It was an undercover operation as part of the war. And that was in the Horde."

It seemed that Melog was disagreeing with her claim. And being pedantic about it - or facetious. Not being able to directly communicate with Melog was a bit frustrating, but it was merely a nuisance. And Sam couldn't really expect Catra to serve as a translator for every quip the other cat made.

The General would, though. And he would probably find it incredibly amusing to banter with Melog through Catra.

She pushed the thought away. "Anyway, I'll continue to monitor his electronic communications."

"And we'll spy on him in person." Catra nodded. "And if we don't find anything, we'll go after the actor."

The man was currently under observation by some of the General's 'acquaintances' who owed him a favour or two, as he had called it. "If you turn up nothing here," Sam told Catra.

"If we don't find anything, we can poke him and see how he reacts." Catra cocked her head to the side, and her ears perked up. "Melog can't read minds, but he can detect emotions. Should give us some clue." Suddenly, she frowned at her friend. "I don't always annoy everyone, so if he is annoyed, that's still a clue!"

Sam couldn't help snorting at that. It was a bit like seeing the General and Daniel banter during a mission.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, December 3rd, 1999

Smith lived in a pretty nice house, in Catra's opinion. It was on the outskirts of Washington, but that was a nice area in America. You wouldn't catch General Juliet living in the countryside instead of in the palace. Or any of Mermista's admirals. But the United States didn't have a palace - the White House came closest, but anyone could see it wasn't a palace; it was much too small to house a court.

No one inside.

She nodded at Melog. That was what the shuttle's scanners had shown them, but it was always good to double-check intel.

"Good," she whispered. "Now, let's take a closer look at his home." She didn't expect to find anything incriminating, but if you could do recon in person, you did it. It would help with finding the best approach to observing the general's home life.

And she was curious how the man lived. She had only visited one Earth general's home before, and Jack hadn't been a general at the time.

Breaking into the man's home was easy. Not suspiciously easy - they had magitech tools to fool his security system, and Catra had been sneaking into restricted areas all the time as a cadet - but she would have expected a bit more from someone apparently trying to blackmail the Alliance. Or taking a shot at a personal friend of She-Ra, if Jack was right.

"Looks a bit… drab," she commented once they were both inside. "Nothing too personal."

Family.

Melog stared at a couple of pictures on the sideboard next to the couch.

"Those are the same pictures he has on his desk." In fact, the living room left a similar impression as the man's office. Tidy. Neat. Like the barracks before an inspection.

Catra wasn't sure what that said about the man, but it was something.

*****

Above the Pentagon, Washington D.C., United States of America, December 3rd, 1999

Smith is a … workaholic is the Earth term, Catra thought. It was past eight, and he was still in his office in the Pentagon. Which was a weird structure, in her opinion; until the shield generator had been installed after the United States joined the Alliance, it hadn't had any protection from air or orbital attacks. Why would you put most of your military leadership into an easily identifiable and destroyable building? And in the same region as the not-palace of your supreme leader? Sure, they had the bunker where

they had first placed the Stargate, but most of the people running the military were in Washington.

Of course, the people in the bunker might be enough to keep the armed forces going just fine, but if that was the case, why would they need the Pentagon in the first place?

Well, they had shield generators now, so the point was probably moot, but she made a note to ask Jack about it anyway. At the least, his answer would be entertaining.

Much more entertaining than tracking Smith. She sighed and stretched her arms over her head, then shifted a bit in the shuttle's seat. "No change?"

No.

Melog was sprawled out on the backrests of the two seas behind her in a very comfy position. She would also have to try that when she wasn't nominally on pilot duty. And they weren't in the middle of an operation.

"You know, with all those millions of soldiers, I would have expected you to have more spies available," she commented, twisting her head a bit to look at Sam, who had installed herself at the comm console in the back. Which, Catra noted, fit her gear perfectly. Jack must have had that installed just for her, but whether he had done so intentionally or not was another question that should have an entertaining answer. Or reaction.

"Smith is a four-star general. We cannot be sure how much influence he has in the various government agencies, so using American assets to investigate him increases the risk that he will become aware of it," Sam replied without taking her eyes off the screen in front of her.

The man would be expecting an investigation anyway since his acting stooge had made contact with SG-1, though it was a fair point. "And so you came to us."

"Yes."

Not to any of America's allied nations. No, Jack trusted Catra and her friends more than anyone else amongst his contacts to handle this crisis. Well, they were his friends, so that was normal. Still, it said something about Earth that…

A beep from the scanner interrupted her thoughts. Smith was moving! Catra twisted and grabbed the shuttle controls, tracking Smith's icon on the holoprojection display in front of her.

Smith was moving through the Pentagon towards the exit. His usual exit, close to his car.

"No change in his routine," Sam reported.

"Yeah," Catra replied.

She checked the sensors in case another shuttle, or one of the old choppers, but those were growing scarce here, was arriving, but the sky was clear. Grinning, she accelerated a bit and started following Smith once he got in his car. "Fancy a car chase?"

"We are invisible to him."

No challenge.

"Spoilports." She chuckled. Still, they had to be pretty close for Melog to sense the man's emotions so she could at least practice some nap-of-the-earth flying. Which would be more fun if the Americans didn't have all those flimsy powerlines crossing the airspace.

Still, she managed to avoid them all - it wasn't hard with how slow those ground cars here were going.

Anticipation.

"Oh?" That was new. "Smith is expecting something," she said for Sam's benefit.

“There’s nothing on his schedule,” Sam replied.

“He might have planned a romantic evening with his wife.” He certainly should, in Catra’s opinion, for how much time he was spending at work and not with her.

She felt Melog’s amusement clearly. Her friend didn’t think Smith would either.

“You did not see any preparations for such an event in his home or office,” Sam said.

“You can plan a romantic evening without any of that,” Catra pointed out. She had done so herself plenty of times. Though Sam was more like Adora, who couldn’t plan anything without at least a whiteboard and three different pens to draw on it.

Anticipation grows.

“Oh! He’s growing more excited!” Catra reported.

“He’s still driving along the highway,” Sam said. “But he’s slowing down a little. A few miles, tops.”

Catra frowned. There was nothing down there, and the traffic looked normal, so… Wait! There was a truckstop, or whatever those things were called. A big parking lot with a cheap diner. But Smith wasn’t driving off the highway - he drove past the exit. And accelerated again to his usual speed.

Disappointment.

“He was checking the parking lot,” Catra said. “And whatever he expected wasn’t there. Or whomever.”

“He didn’t call or mail anyone about a meeting here,” Sam added.

Catra grinned. “Someone’s trying to be clever.” But not clever enough for them.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 4th, 1999

"If anyone asks, we are inspecting a potential site for the Alliance base on the Moon," Jack O'Neill said as he entered his stealth shuttle.

"We are supposed to do the Moon survey in two days, sir." Carter frowned at him.

"So we've decided to reschedule because something else came up." Jack grinned - she was always a little peeved when her schedule was changed. "It's even true. And it's not as if we're the actual surveyors, anyway. We're just checking to see if we like the locations."

"So, you've got the final word?" Catra asked. She was sprawled all over the pilot seat in a position that would break Jack's spine if he attempted it. "I wasn't aware we're building a special forces base on your Moon."

"We aren't. It's supposed to host an early warning system and secondary fleet base."

"Why would the Alliance need either?" Catra frowned. "We've got the spy bot network covering the entire system - and the area beyond it - and you've got plenty of secondary bases."

"It's mostly to lay claim to the Moon, I assume." Jack shrugged. "Or prevent that someone else lays claim to it. Like the United Nations."

"OK." Catra nodded.

Her reaction made sense, of course. Others might have commented that the Moon belonged to all of Earth, but Catra came from a planet where Bright Moon laid claim to three moons. Or she just didn't care. Jack was betting on the latter.

“Anyway,” he said, “it’s mostly Carter who’s involved since she’s supposed to build the sensors used there. But guarding the station might be part of my command’s job - they’re still sorting that out - and doing that will allow me to send my folks out on patrols on the moon, which will be good training, so we’re involved as well.” And they were friends with Princess of Power She-Ra, Supreme Commander of the Alliance, and while Jack wouldn’t really abuse that - unless some idiot picked a truly awful place - others would, and the officers responsible for planning this were playing it safe.

Damn, he was starting to think like a politician instead of a soldier! Jack shook his head.

“Sir, if we’re supposed to use the survey as a cover, then they will expect us to actually do the survey.”

He made a dismissive gesture with his hand. “Just pick a location you like.”

“But there are several important factors that will influence this choice,” she protested.

“And I am sure that you’ve already considered them all.” He flushed her a grin.

She actually blushed a little in return. “Yes, but strictly based on the data I had already - I haven’t surveyed the actual locations myself.”

“Just check the best location, and if it’s good enough, pick it. We’ve got the technology to build a base anywhere anyway. We’ve got more important things to do.”

“Not every decision has to be planned out like a night assault with green troops,” Catra commented.

Jack nodded in agreement.

Carter obviously disagreed, but she was in the minority here. Not that this was a democracy, anyway.

He clapped his hands together, then took control of the shuttle from the co-pilot seat. "So, let's head to orbit and go over what we found out about Smith's dead drop!"

"Well, sir," Carter began as Jack took the shuttle up, "we've run the records we recovered from the diner through the Space Lab's main computer, but we didn't get any suspicious matches. Whoever General Smith might be exchanging messages with probably paid in cash. We've analysed the data from a traffic control camera next, and we've placed advanced sensors in the area, and we have a potential hit there, sir."

Jack refrained from commenting on whether or not Carter had acquired this data legally. They couldn't risk Smith or one of the man's unknown backers catching wind of their investigation. That was a good excuse, at least. "A potential hit?" He checked their course and the sensors, then looked over his shoulder at her screen. It showed a particular car. "The FBI?"

"Yes, sir."

*****

Potential Base Site, Moon, Solar System, December 4th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, he's in contact with an FBI spook. Special Agent Wilkinson. Hank Wilkinson."

No one chuckled at Jack O'Neill's Bond impression. Catra probably didn't get the reference, and Carter was staring at her screen, trying to do a complete survey on the sly, but Daniel…

…was gazing at his wife.

Jack cleared his throat. "Focus, people! This whole thing just became a bit more complicated!"

"I would say so," Daniel replied. "It's one thing to investigate a general, it's another to investigate the FBI."

"Why?" Catra asked. "As you told me, you don't have the official authority to do either."

"Ah, well… the FBI is in charge of counter-espionage," Daniel said.

"So is the Alliance Joint Military Intelligence. And they have better stuff," Catra retorted. "Or did you funnel Alliance gear to your local organisations?"

Jack wouldn't be surprised if such a thing had happened, under the table or disguised as 'testing potential uses' or whatever excuse the gang around Kinsey could come up with, but he would have expected that to go to the NID.

"We would have detected any non-registered piece of advanced technology in use in the USA as long as it depended on Naquadah or used hyperspace fields or waves," Carter commented. "They cannot detect this shuttle."

Which was one reason Jack had wanted a stealth shuttle as his private shuttle. No way to track his movements should he have to alter his filed flight path.

"But we'd still be spying on the FBI. That's…"

"...perfectly fine, Daniel," Jack interrupted his friend. "We're going to get to the bottom of this one way or the other. Besides, if there's corruption in the FBI, we best find out as soon as possible." And success generally meant forgiveness, as long as you didn't break too many rules or laws. Or made the wrong people look stupid.

"So, we bug the FBI?" Catra asked.

"Not quite," Jack said. "Or not yet."

"We'll use standard electronic information gathering."

“You can call it hacking, Carter.” Jack grinned at her.

“It’s not limited to accessing FBI computer systems. We’re also going to use advanced sensors to track key suspects.”

“So, hacking and stalking.” He nodded. “We need to find out if there’s a rat in the FBI or if they are used as stooges.”

“Stooges?” Catra frowned. “Like in those old movies?”

“Patsies,” Daniel explained. “Being used as unwitting tools of the real culprit.”

“Ah.” Catra nodded, then nodded again at Melog. “Right, shouldn’t be too hard - if we can check the suspects’ reaction.”

“Which brings us back to Hank Wilkinson,” Jack said. “Not quite first of his class, but not bad either - you don’t make Special Agent if you’re stupid or lazy. Good career so far, but he’s fallen a bit behind on promotions. Good in the field but ‘untested as a leader’, according to his file.” That could mean he either wasn’t good with people - unlikely based on the cases he had solved - or he had stepped on the wrong superior’s toes. Or he had simply been in the way of someone’s protege. Jack knew how office politics worked. And based on what they knew so far, Wilkinson didn’t. He didn’t have a patron and didn’t know where the right bodies were buried. He seemed to be the stereotypical honest detective in a not-so-honest organisation. *Seemed*. “I wonder if he’s a stooge or player,” Jack said.

“We’ll find out,” Catra said. “Once you put us down on the planet again.” She cocked her head at the other cat. “Yes, it’s getting late. Tomorrow, then.”

By then, they should have a better picture of the situation in the FBI. He looked at Carter. “Carter?”

“A few more minutes, sir,” she said without looking up from her screen. “The preliminary scans are done, but a geological survey takes a bit more time.”

"Wouldn't want our base to vanish into some sinkhole we missed, yes," Jack said, nodding.

"Given the moon's geology, there is no danger of sinkholes - and we would spot such an anomaly in the early stages of building," Carter replied. "Even if we don't use Tok'ra tunnelling techniques."

"Which we are supposed to use," he reminded her. "To preserve the Moon's environment or something."

"And for camouflage. Like the First Ones did with Alpha," Catra commented. "Too bad you can't completely hide its existence from your people."

Jack sighed. The crazies were already spreading conspiracy theories about secret alien moonbases. This *actual* hidden base wouldn't help. Too many politicians had access to the Alliance's budget numbers. At least the Ancients' little mad scientist base was still classified somewhat. If people started fearing that they would be turned into animals…

"Apart from the concerns the United Nations have voiced, several groups are protesting the militarisation of the Moon," Daniel said. "And there are concerns about the effects it might have on Earth's magic, given the importance of the moon in myths. To be fair, we don't know much about that."

"It didn't affect Etherian magic," Catra said.

"But Earth magic is different," Daniel retorted. "We don't know if that's the case here as well."

"And it could affect Etherian magic without you being aware of it - the research base has been on the moon since before your kingdoms were founded," Sha're pointed out, "so without older records, you cannot know if there are any differences."

That was a good point, but as long as things worked, Jack was okay with not caring about the details of magic. It was bad enough that even without the Chinese being in the Alliance or

having a realistic chance of joining the Alliance, some people wanted Feng Shui consultants to approve of every planned construction.

What was next, sacrificing goats to bless new ships? Jack was almost glad about some good, old-fashioned corruption plot to deal with instead of that nonsense.

*****

Cultural Exchange Part 4

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 4th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and it's with great pleasure that I am here, announcing a performance of one of the Asgard's greatest epics, the 'Lost Sons of Vanir', a recording loaned to us by our guests from Asgard."

Adora clapped encouragingly when Glimmer nodded at Thor, Freyr and Penegal, who were sitting next to Adora in the first row of the theatre. She leaned over and whispered: "Thank you again for allowing this."

Thor smiled at her. "When you told us that your only examples of our culture were from Loki's private collection, we had to show you the real culture of Asgard. Even as a child, that rogue had no taste."

Adora kept smiling and nodded. She agreed with Thor's judgement of Loki's taste, but saying so would feel like talking about Loki behind his back. "We've been looking forward to this." Especially after the visit to Ketro and Jesa's farm. The Asgard had overwhelmed the farmers about the magitech they used to till the land with questions that would have been better addressed to the actual creators of the various tools. And she best not think about the Asgard's opinion on using draft animals and magitech together.

But that was over now, and the next day, the Asgard would visit Mystacor, where they could satisfy their curiosity about magitech. That should put them in a good mood, Adora hoped. And make them more receptive to Etheria's culture.

Meanwhile, Glimmer had stepped down from the stage and retook her seat in the front row, next to Bow and Adora, as the lights dimmed and the audience quietened down.

Once the theatre was mostly silent and dark, the stage was suddenly illuminated by a dim blueish glow, which turned into a holoprojection of an Asgard. According to Thor, it was a famous performer, Baldr. A famous *dead* performer, Adora reminded herself, wincing at how embarrassing it had been when she had asked the Asgard if he would like to visit and perform himself.

Then the holographic projection started to speak, and Adora sat straighter. This was it - genuine Asgard culture. Mainstream culture, as Daniel would say.

"In ages past, when faced with dire news, the Asgard were united, and yet…"

Baldr sounded as if he were half-dead already. Adora pressed her lips together - this was something Catra would have said - and forced herself to focus on the performance.

*****

"...and so the Vanir left, never to be seen again."

Adora smiled and clapped her hands as the holographic projection on the stage bowed their head. She was genuinely happy - that the performance was now over. If the recordings Loki had given them of the Asgard epics had been bad, then this - Thor's favourite epic, apparently - was worse. The delivery had been just… 'Wooden' would be a compliment. If Jack were here, he'd be making jokes about robot performers. And if the performer had been a bot, Entrapta would have offered to repair it.

But, she noted with a side glance, the Asgard had liked the performance. At least, they looked moved. Especially Thor.

"If we show another such epic, we'll have a rebellion on our hands. Or a lynching," Glimmer whispered.

It was hyperbole, of course. But Adora was glad Catra was on Earth. Her lover wouldn't have been able to keep her tongue in check, Adora was sure.

At least Glimmer was clapping her hands as well, if not very enthusiastically. Only Bow and his Dads showed genuine enthusiasm in the front row, from what Adora could tell.

"That was fascinating!" George said.

"Oh, yes!" Lance was beaming. "It is so very interesting to see a truly alien culture - it seems that humans share similar cultural traits, possibly influenced by our shared First Ones heritage, though we'd have to research this more thoroughly, which would explain why Earth media are so popular on Etheria, while Asgard culture does not resonate nearly as well with us."

"Well, I found the story very interesting - a tribe of Asgard, lost in the galaxy," Bow said.

"From a historical point of view, of course, the story is interesting, but the performance itself utterly failed to entertain humans," Lance retorted. "A quick look at the audience proves that, especially given the circumstances."

"I see," Thor said.

Adora winced while Lance grimaced. Bow's dad was honest, but he probably shouldn't have said that out loud in the presence of their guests.

Though she couldn't really say that he was wrong. On any point.

*****

Above the J. Edgar Hoover Building, Washington D.C., United States of America, December 4th, 1999

"This would be much easier if we simply monitored the FBI's electronic communication," Samantha Carter pointed out. It would also, if you stretched definitions, be covered by the mandate of the Alliance. Of course, no one would believe that they actually feared a Goa'uld plot in this case, but it would be hard to disprove it. She turned her seat to look at the General.

"Yep, but we can't." He grinned. "They're using a dead drop - I doubt they'll be using electronic communications for anything juicy."

Sam pressed her lips together as she nodded. That was a logical deduction. She still didn't like it.

"Well, at least we can bug their offices while we're infiltrating their hideout," Catra commented. "So, you don't have to do that at a later date."

"I don't expect bugging the FBI offices will be necessary after this," Sam retorted. It would also be hideously illegal.

Catra somehow managed to shrug while sprawled over the co-pilot seat's armrest. "If there's one traitor, there could be more. Besides, they're your spy hunters, so they're an obvious target for infiltration."

"Most spies would consider the FBI an obvious organisation to avoid," Sam said.

Catra snorted. "Not the good spies. They would know that they'd be safest pretending to hunt spies - they would be aware of any investigations."

Sam glanced at the General. He was the closest they had to an expert in such undercover operations.

He frowned a little. "Well, it would be a bold strategy but also a high-risk one. Surrounding yourself with people trained to spot spies is not a safe tactic. Could have a great payoff, but the odds of surviving it for long aren't good. Of course, sometimes you don't need to survive undercover for long. But getting inside would be very hard since any new recruit would be vetted."

"By possibly corrupt people. Once you have a foot in the door…" Catra shrugged again. "But it's your decision. Unless it's Goa'uld-related."

“We can’t determine whether something is related to a Goa’uld plot without investigating,” Sam retorted.

Catra grinned. “Then I guess mission Bug-the-FBI is on.”

“Yeah, the logic is flawless,” the General said.

Sam didn’t roll her eyes at Catra and him. But she huffed under her breath as she turned back to her computer. She really didn’t like breaking the law so blatantly. Hacking a computer was just… collecting data. It was a kind of unorthodox research, from a certain point of view.

She blinked. She probably had watched Star Wars too often. Teal’c was to blame for that.

In any case, if this operation failed, she probably would have to emigrate to Etheria. As would the General. Of course, that would also mean that the UCMJ wouldn’t apply to them any more, and… She shut down that annoying thought. She was better than that!

“So, how’s the hacking of the FBI security going?” Catra asked, craning her neck to look at Sam upside down.

“You shouldn’t have any problem bypassing their security system,” Sam replied. Not with the advanced technology at their disposal. And with Melog’s illusion power, that could effectively render the two cats invisible. No challenge, as Melog supposedly said.

“Yeah. But do you have anything else?” Catra didn’t change her position. Sam felt her back hurt just looking at her twisted form.

“Not at this point.” Nothing that her preliminary search had flagged. Of course, she might have missed something, but that was why she was running a much more thorough - and slower - search of the FBI data centre she had hacked.

But if Smith and Wilkinson were as careful as they had shown to be so far, this wouldn’t get them any actionable intel. At most, Sam was hoping for clues and hints at what Wilkinson was doing -

she already knew he wasn't running an official investigation that required contact with Smith; Smith didn't appear in the databanks at all.

And neither did anything connected to Kinsey or the NID so far. That was disappointing but hardly unexpected. They wouldn't have been half as dangerous if they had been incompetent, and their influence on the US government agencies would have only grown after the President had relied on their support to push through crucial policies to secure the Alliance with Etheria.

"Well, let's see what we can find out, then!" Catra got up from her seat with a fluid grace that Sam couldn't have pulled off in her best form, and Melog joined her.

Sam checked the scanner one last time. No sign of any improved security that she wasn't already aware of and had neutralised. Then she nodded. "Go!"

Catra grinned, then turned to her companion. "You heard her!"

Moments later, they faded from view - no, Sam corrected herself; an illusion of an empty shuttle interior covered them. Melog was showing off - they would have to create a different illusion for the building's roof. And for the rappelling down.

Still, they knew what they were doing. "Clear," she announced,

"Gotcha!" The general replied.

A moment later, the ramp was lowered, and Sam barely heard feet - and claws - on the metal surface before the shuttle's system informed her that they had jumped off.

"You know, seeing this makes the CIA look a little less stupid for trying their ESP experiments in the 70s," the General commented. "I wonder if they found a way to make it work this time, with magic returned."

Sam made a noncommittal noise and focused on her screen before he could find a way to make her hack the CIA to search for such programs.

She was sure that they were running more than one, anyway. As would be any other intel agency. Even the FBI, actually.

She frowned. That was the only threat she could imagine to this operation. But they hadn't found any hint of such a program being run here in Washington - all such research was supposed to be conducted in Quantico.

*****

1. **Edgar Hoover Building, Washington D.C., United States of America, December 4th, 1999**

Catra slid down the rappelling rope and landed lightly on her feet on the roof of the FBI headquarters. Melog didn't bother with the rope at all and simply jumped down the few metres from the shuttle ramp.

"Show off," she whispered and felt their amusement and some smugness in return.

The light's hue showed that they were inside an illusion of an empty roof right now. And above a half-empty building - it was Saturday, and most people didn't work on Saturday or Sunday. At least if they were working for the FBI.

Catra was glad of that - it made her mission easier. Usually, with a building that size, she'd sneak through the air vents - using the hallways and taking out whoever you met before they could sound the alarm was not possible since there could be no sign of their intrusion at all. But with Melog's help, they could just go down the facade and break through a window. No one would see them.

No challenge.

“The challenge is finding proof,” she whispered. Any proof useful for stopping this plot.

She peered over the edge of the roof. “Coast’s clear.”

Melog moved the illusion - Catra could tell from the way the light just changed a little bit in her sight - while she fastened the rope to the roof. She could hear Entrpata’s voice in her kind as she used the self-adhesive option of the rope: ‘It’s the new and improved self-dissolving climbing rope mark II - this one won’t dissolve spontaneously; well, it didn’t so far in testing without the correct catalyst - and you can use a different catalysator to make it self-adhesive! Either the rope or the material you attach it to will break before the adhesive!’ Jack had ordered a cargo container’s worth of the rope for his troops. But his expression when Catra had asked what the troops would get up to with the adhesive rope in their spare time…

Focus on the mission, she told herself as she slid over the roof’s edge and down the facade. She reached Wilkinson’s office in no time and perched on the windowsill while she peered inside. There he was, shuffling papers on his desk. Which was placed so she couldn’t see what he was reading from her point of view.

Well, they already knew he was competent. And a workaholic. No partner, no kids, and distant parents - which was a point in his favour, said parents being part of a rather bigoted community according to their research, while Wilkinson himself hadn’t visited a church unless it had been for a wedding or a funeral ever since he had left his home town.

Waiting. Busywork.

Oh? Catra’s ears perked up. That was interesting. Busywork on a Saturday? And waiting for something or someone? Time to get to work! They weren’t here to spy through windows; any drone could have done that.

She quickly climbed up and then over to the next office, resisting the urge to use her claws. Leaving suits and gauges in the facade would be a clear sign she had been there.

This office was empty, as expected, and she quickly had the security disabled and the window opened. Bracing herself, she held out her arms and whispered 'Ready" through her comm.

Coming.

A few moments later, Melog came down the rope, changing forms into a slinkier form before reverting back once they could jump off and into the office.

Catra used the catalysator pen to dissolve the rope before closing the windows, watching for a moment while the rope seemed to fade from view, turning into smoke that blew away in the light breeze.

Messy.

Yeah, the desk was messy. But it was not very interesting - the files belonged to some boring financial case or something. Nothing related to their investigation. They had checked beforehand.

They had picked this office since it was next to Wilkinson's - and because the owner was messy. Which meant they would be very unlikely to notice a few well-hidden changes to their office walls.

She pulled a set of tools out of her belt and started to drill, or 'etch' according to Entrapta, who had made them - through the wall. Silent even to her ears, there was no way Wilkinson would hear that. And since the hole wouldn't go all through, he couldn't spot it either.

A few minutes later, she slid the bug into the hole, plugging it with a battery that would last years and some plaster. "Done!"

Visitor.

Oh? Perfect timing, then! Catra would have hated to wait for hours for whatever Wilkinson was expecting to turn up. Almost as much as she would have hated to sit through an Asgard Epic. Poor Adora.

She grinned and switched her communicator to the bug's frequency. Not even regular Alliance scanners would detect that both Entrapta and Sam had assured her, and since they had created said scanners, they would know.

She heard someone knock on the door, followed by Wilkinson snapping: *"Come in!"*

"Wilkinson."

"Paris."

A female voice. They and Wilkinson sounded… familiar. But not too friendly.

The door closed. Footsteps. Lighter ones than Wilkinson's.

"You know the brass still isn't convinced we're ready for work. We're still training. And experimenting."

"Consider this training, then."

"I'm saying that I don't have any experience with this. Not a little - none, Wilkinson."

"You already told me that."

"Just clarifying it again."

Wilkinson snorted, but it didn't sound as if he was actually amused. *"You don't need to cover your ass with me. The brass isn't convinced your work can be used in court. And they won't be convinced until the Supreme Court approves it. But I won't need this for evidence. All I need is additional security."*

Catra heard the woman snort. *"I'd say you're paranoid, but… this isn't for your official case, is it?"*

"Safer if you don't know. It might damage your career if you knew and were caught."

"Then I'll find something else. In case you missed it, anyone with a talent for magic is currently headhunted by everyone. I could be making the big bucks in no time, Wilkinson."

"And yet, you stayed with the FBI."

Catra hissed. A sorceress? And Wilkinson wanted her for 'security'?

They hadn't planned for that!

Problem.

Definitely a problem, yes. If she could spot illusions… Catra pressed her lips together. They didn't know much about Earth magic - no one did. But two things had been observed so far. Earth magic often dealt with 'spirits' and similar beings or things conjured to do something, like the Wild Hunt. And all the myths about guardian and vengeance spirits. And the other thing was subtle stuff, like curses that brought you bad luck or sickness. Either possibility was bad news.

"Because they won't expect me to fight aliens with my mind."

Wilkinson snorted again. *"But they could probably offer better training."*

"Not according to what I heard."

"And what did you hear?"

"That the aliens have no idea about what magic we can do, and so can't train us any better than anyone else."

Catra frowned. The Alliance really needed to get their act together and start training sorceresses.

"Well, it's your career. Your decision," Wilkinson said. *"I'm just a special agent on a case."*

"On an unofficial case where you fear magical interference. Did you go through the X-Files?"

X-Files? Catra frowned. She would have to look those up. This sounded important.

"No. I'm investigating a case of corruption."

Or not, Catra corrected herself.

"And you think magic is involved, or you wouldn't have called me. No - you want additional security. You think someone might use magic to interfere with your investigation!" After a moment, Paris continued: *"Oh, don't make such a face! Anyone could have deduced that!"*

"It's safer if you don't know the details. I just need some way to keep magic off me."

"'Keep magic off you'? That's a big thing, Wilkinson. Ever since the first news of killing spirits, everyone wants a way to stop them. But no one knows how to do it."

"No one?" Wilkinson sounded sceptical.

"It's hard to test things. We've got several potential ways to block curses, but we don't know anyone who can curse people to test it."

"I'm volunteering. Can't hurt to try, at least."

Paris scoffed. *"Oh, you sweet summer child - it very well can hurt. That much we know."*

"I trust you."

"I always knew you were an idiot."

Catra snorted softly. She knew that tone. Those two had history.

After another moment of silence, Wilkinson asked: *"So, what can the best witch of the FBI do against magic?"*

"I'm not a witch. I am a thaumaturgist."

"That's what they're going with?"

"They hope it won't piss off the crazies as much as 'witch' would since it also has religious connotations."

Wilkinson scoffed. *"As someone raised by such crazies, trust me when I tell you it won't help."*

"I know. But our boss thinks he can have a magic division without the religious right frothing at the mouth about satanic government spooks. Even though we've recruited a priest recently."

"Really? A priest?" Wilkinson laughed.

"An exorcist. As a consultant."

"I'm starting to have doubts about this…"

"He's actually very nice. And he knows a lot that might turn out to be working now that we have magic back."

Wilkinson scoffed. *"Don't come crying if he tries to burn you at the stake."*

"Oh, stop it! The Pope himself has said that magic was God's creation, so it's not inherently evil. Any good Catholic knows that now."

Wilkinson scoffed again. *"So, what can you do for me? Pray for my soul?"*

"Do you want my help or not? I can do something more productive on a Saturday than listen to you regurgitate your childhood trauma."

"Sorry." Wilkinson didn't sound sorry. *"I need whatever magic you can do."*

"And what I can do depends on what we're facing. You mentioned 'interference'. What kind of threat are we talking about? Curses? Spirits?"

Catra cocked her head.

After a second, Wilkinson answered: *"I don't know exactly. Any kind is possible."*

"Any kind?" Paris sounded annoyed. *"Don't give me that bullshit. I know you. You wouldn't have called me if you didn't have something more concrete."*

A sigh followed. *"I'm investigating a corruption case with an Etherian connection."*

"Shit."

Catra suppressed a snort. Well, they already knew that, but it was nice to have confirmation.

"Yeah. So… anything is possible if I get too close. I could trip over a vine and break my neck. Or freeze to death in my bedroom."

"What the hell are you investigating? That sounds like…"

"Yeah. Corruption at the highest level. I've got an informant in the army, and the things he told me…"

"The Etherians all have diplomatic immunity. What do you think you can do?"

"The Etherians might have diplomatic immunity, but their business partners on Earth don't. And those are profiting from the corruption."

"Shit. You really meant the highest levels."

"I told you it would have been better if you didn't know. If you want to back out…"

"You know me better than that."

"Yeah. Yeah, I do."

Catra heard Paris take a deep breath. *"Alright. Let's start with basic charms of protection against curses. We haven't been able to test them, but we've got the wording confirmed from different sources - thanks to Father Ryan, actually. So… just relax and let me work."*

That sounded like an excellent opportunity to exfiltrate to Catra. Get back to the shuttle while the FBI sorceress was busy casting whatever on Wilkinson.

She turned to look at Melog and nodded. "Time to move."

Yes.

*****

Above Washington D.C., United States of America, December 4th, 1999

"So, my office is now protected against magic?"

"It's supposed to be protected against evil magic as the ancient Romans considered it. We haven't actually been able to test that since we don't have anyone who can do evil magic."

"You don't?"

"We're the FBI, Wilkinson. Not the CIA."

"Point. And I guess you don't want to ask them for help testing this since that would give away that the FBI is building up a magic division."

"Yes."

"So much for the spirit of cooperation in the face of a shared enemy."

"That didn't work with the USSR, so why would it work with aliens?"

"Right. Anyway, thank you for doing this for me."

"We don't know if what I did is actually working. I did something - I can feel it lingering - but I can't promise it will protect you against Etherian magic."

"It's better than nothing."

"You still know how to make a woman feel appreciated, Wilkinson."

Jack O'Neill snorted. He wished the two FBI spooks would talk about the unofficial investigation Wilkinson was apparently running, but at least their banter was entertaining - and offered insight into the FBI's magic program.

"You know, I thought the whole 'our real enemies are the other American intelligence agencies' was just a TV thing," Catra commented from behind him.

He checked the autopilot - still set on automatic evasion should a plane or shuttle approach - and then headed back to Carter's station. "It's the capitalist way - a healthy competition keeps everyone sharp."

"Having your intel organisations run secret programs without oversight or control doesn't sound healthy to me," Catra retorted.

"It's healthy for certain people," Jack said. "For their bank account and influence, at least."

"That sounds like that corruption the guy was talking about."

"Yep."

Catra rolled her eyes. And Carter was staring a bit too intently at her laptop - even though Jack's shuttle had a holoprojector; it was great for briefings, and Jack was looking forward to movie nights once Hollywood got the hang of actual 3D-movies. Or someone started making games for it. But the FBI agents were still talking.

"So, who are you investigating?"

"Paris! You don't want to get involved in this any more than you are already, trust me."

"I'm already involved too much. You know that the kind of people you were talking about won't really stop with you if things go wrong. And if they find out about you, they'll find out about me as well."

Jack grinned. That was exactly what they were hoping for! "Yeah, Wilkinson, tell her everything about your investigation!" he muttered. "Leave nothing out!"

Catra snorted at that, and he heard Carter chuckle briefly, but he was focused on the two FBI spooks.

Wilkinson sighed. *"Alright. I've got a source in the Alliance high command who stumbled upon hints of corruption. Misuse of military assets for private gain, nepotism, illegal operations, both authorised and unauthorised, smuggling and trading favours."*

Business as usual, in other words, Jack thought with another snort. But he had thought they had done a decent job keeping that stuff down to trivial levels.

"A source?"

"Yes. An old friend of the old director. They contacted me."

"And asked you to investigate this on your own time?"

"That was my decision."

"And no one who knew you could have ever predicted that, right, Wilkinson?"

"Still my decision."

"It's your career."

"Damn right."

"So, you're investigating corrupt generals and magical princesses."

"Yes."

"And I thought becoming an FBI Thaumaturgist was weird."

"I've investigated Saudi princes and princesses before."

"And that investigation was shut down by the government."

"This one won't."

"And what makes you think that, Wilkinson?"

"The government stepped on too many toes to get into the Alliance. People went along with it because they had to, but they didn't like it. All the new laws, the constitutional amendment, magic and gay marriage… A lot of people are waiting for a chance to strike back."

"I didn't take you for a bigot, Wilkinson."

"I'm not a bigot. What people do in their own bedrooms is their business. And I don't give a damn about the Bible. But I am not blind to the fact that many people do have issues with all the changes that were forced on us."

"And you want to use them? You know how that usually turns out."

"All I want is criminals brought to justice, Paris. And justice is blind."

"And that's the corniest line I've heard in months," Jack commented. "And I work with magical princesses."

"I'll tell Adora you said that," Catra said.

"Do it. I am sure she can need the laughs." The Asgard were proving to be frustrating guests, as Jack had heard.

"Whatever. So, what are you investigating?"

"Smuggling. Earth media are the hottest thing in Etheria, and that means merchandise brings more money than drugs. And Earth is crazy for anything magical."

"But the only way to transfer goods is through the Stargate - or by spaceship, but a trip to Etheria takes weeks."

"Exactly. But if you control the Stargate and the fleet, that's not a problem. And guess who managed to get a personal stealth shuttle for private use? The former second-in-command of Stargate Command!"

Jack blinked. "They think I am smuggling movie merchandise in my shuttle? They think *I* am corrupt?"

"Well, we're currently using your 'private' shuttle." Catra shrugged at Jack's glare. "The other generals are probably just jealous they can't use a stealth shuttle to make money."

"I am not using the shuttle to make money!" Jack spat.

But some people would think he was.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 4th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"It seems Asgard and Etherian culture is more different than we expected."

Adora pressed her lips together and reminded herself that honesty was the best policy before she nodded. Thor was right, anyway. "I fear so."

"I wouldn't say that," Bow said. "Etheria has a very diverse culture. Of course, fundamental aspects are shared by every kingdom, but every kingdom has unique cultural expressions and styles. We just haven't found the kingdoms whose people like Asgard epics. I mean, really like - it's not that they are disliked or anything, really!"

He meant well, but he wasn't a good liar - his smile looked as forced as it had when they had visited his dads for the first time, Adora noticed.

And Thor hadn't been there, but he must have noticed something since he tilted his head slightly and stared at Bow with an expression that would likely have included raised eyebrows if Asgard had them. "And yet, according to what we were told, Earth media is 'all the rage' across Etheria. It seems your planet's cultures share this as well."

"Well…" Bow winced.

"We can't be sure that everyone thinks your finest epics are boring until we've got enough data to make such a conclusion!" Entrapta cut in. "Our sample size is not large enough, and the people present today were not chosen at random either, so this is not representative."

Freyr made a snorting sound. "Correct me if I am wrong, but I assume that you picked people you thought would favour us."

"We did?" Entrapta looked at Glimmer, then at Adora.

Adora winced. “Yes, we did.” She reminded herself again that honesty was the best policy. “We wouldn’t pick people who disliked the Asgard.”

“Oh? I thought you might have hoped that if even people who were prejudiced against Asgard were won over, it would have made a great impression.” Entrapta nodded. “But even so, we need a larger sample size to draw sufficiently solid conclusions from this. It’s not like we have data from past samples to extrapolate from - we’re breaking new ground here!”

“And,” Freyr went on with a kind of smile, “the reason you invited us to visit your planet wasn’t to make your people like our epics but to show us your civilisation and build trust.”

Well, he was right, but it would have been a great help if Etherians liked Asgard culture. Adora smiled anyway.

“Well, at least this shows that we’re honest,” Bow said.

Thor frowned at him. “It has to be weighed against, and judged in light of, the circumstances of your involvement with Loki.”

Adora winced again. If they had been honest with the Asgard from the start… But that would have meant breaking their deal with Loki. In hindsight, they should have looked into the whole matter a bit more before making a deal, but… If people needed help, and you could help them, you helped them.

“Anyway,” Glimmer spoke up, “thank you for your performance. We learned something about each other.”

“Yes, we did.” Freyr nodded again.

“And tomorrow, we’ll visit the Scorpion Kingdom so you can see a completely different culture!” Entrapta said. “I’m sure you’ll like it!”

Adora nodded in agreement even though she wasn’t so sure any more.

*****

Fifteen minutes later, she entered her room, sighing.

“I guess the performance went over as expected.”

Catra! Adora beamed at her lover and quickly moved to the bed on which Catra was lounging. “You’re back!”

“Obviously.”

“You didn’t tell me!”

“I didn’t want to disturb your diplomatic event. And I arrived only fifteen minutes ago.”

“Ah.” But she had had enough time to change into her sleepwear.

“You can set me down now, by the way.”

“Mhh.” Adora held her a bit tighter and took a deep breath with her face pressed against Catra’s cheek. And she had taken a shower as well - Adora could smell the shampoo.

“If I have to wriggle out of your arms, your dress might not survive.”

Adora was briefly tempted to let her do it. Losing her clothes sounded very attractive right now, with her lover in her arms. But that would be a waste - Glimmer’s tailor had worked hard on this dress.

So she released Catra and sat down on the bed. “Yes, things didn’t go as we hoped. No one liked the epic.”

“Nice to hear Bright Moon’s population has good taste.”

Adora snorted - weakly - at that, then sighed again. “They know we find them boring.”

“They’re not dumb.”

“How did your day go?”

“Oh, Melog and I had a successful mission. We found out that a rogue FBI agent is investigating Jack for corruption based on General Smith’s information.”

Adora blinked. “What?”

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, December 5th, 1999

“...and they honestly think you’re corrupt?”

Adora sounded incredulous, Samantha Carter noted. Her friend looked like she wanted to pace, but even the General’s large office felt a little crowded right now, with ‘SG-1 Plus’ as he liked to call their old team and Sha’re, and the ‘Best Friends Squad’ and Entrapta present. At least they hadn’t tried to get Emily inside - the bot was guarding the parking lot right now. However, Entrapta had assured everyone that she was listening in through her sensor tool.

Sam had already mentally prepared a response to the General’s inevitable request to harden his office’s anti-eavesdropping protection after that revelation.

“Well, we don’t know if Smith honestly thinks I am corrupt,” the General replied. “But Wilkinson sure does - unless he’s such a good actor, he should replace Mr Blackmail on the next big-ticket movie. But if he were any good at acting, he wouldn’t have been sidelined in the FBI and treated like a rogue agent.”

“But why?” Adora shook her head. “That doesn’t make sense. You haven’t done anything.”

“And nothing was planted on you,” Catra added. “Or in your home. Or as your home.”

“How do you plant a home on someone?” Entrapta asked.

“You register them as the owner,” Catra explained.

“Oh! Did someone hack your government databases and add your name to some properties?” Entrapta leaned forward. “That would be possible, I think, if they don’t check with the owner.”

That was a possibility, Sam had to admit. Not something as blatant as adding the General’s name, but if someone used a shell company or two and built up a convincing set of layers that made it look as if it was meant to hide the actual owner… It was a common way to cheat on taxes. She would have to look into that.

The General frowned - he would have come to the same conclusion. “If this is a frame-up, then they could have done this. And if they pointed the IRS as well as the FBI at it…”

“Oh! That would be great!” Entrapta beamed, and Sam blinked for a moment. Why would her friend think that? “The lack of a central registry for all land ownership in your country is a bit bothersome - you should really organise such a database, you know, it would be so much more efficient - because we would have to hack so many places, but if the IRS is involved, we can just hack their computers!”

Ah. Sam suppressed another sigh. Her friend’s logic was… Well, it wasn’t as if Entrapta was wrong, but she tended to see any problem as a technical challenge and ignored the ethical and legal aspects. Or the political dimension.

“Hacking the IRS?” The General raised his eyebrows and glanced at Sam.

“I believe there are alternatives to such a course of action, sir,” she told him. Not very efficient ones, though.

“Really?” Entrapta frowned a little.

"Well, we don't know if whoever is behind this would go that far," Daniel said. "Or if they have the resources for that. Although if Kinsey is involved…"

Sha're frowned. "If your rival is moving against you, why would he bother with such a ploy? He would know he needs to kill you to be safe from retaliation as long as you have the backing of the Princess Alliance, and your friends won't be fooled by this plot. If he has to kill you anyway, this plot will only serve as a warning for you to prepare for an assassination attempt, negating any usefulness it might have as a distraction."

"Indeed."

Sam reminded herself that Sha're had, as a helpless passenger while her body had been controlled by Amaunet, been a witness to politics in the highest sphere of the Goa'uld Empire. Obviously, this had left an impression similar to Teal'c's experiences as Aphophis's First Prime.

"Ah, yeah, that sounds like something Kinsey might think," the General said, looking a bit surprised himself at Sha're's thoughts, "but he probably would be wary of the possible consequences if I get killed and he was involved."

"But wouldn't he also be wary of the consequences of framing you for corruption?" Sha're retorted.

"Yes, he would," the General agreed. "Which is why I don't think that's the NIDs work. It just looks a bit too… amateurish to me. They tend to hide their tracks a bit better when they do stuff like this. Unless they set off Smith and let him do the work without realising that he's being manipulated."

"But without fake evidence, Wilkinson won't find anything," Adora said with a frown. "So, why would he do this?"

Sam smiled a little. Her Etherian friends weren't naive, but they had a different view of how things were run.

“Ah, it’s not as if there’s nothing suspicious if you look at it from the right - or wrong - angle,” Daniel said, pushing his glasses up.

“Definitely the wrong angle, Daniel,” the General cut in.

“What?” the Etherians were staring at Daniel, then at the General.

“Ah…” Daniel blushed a little. “From the point of view of someone who would abuse their position for personal gain, or someone who is used to dealing with such people, Jack would look suspicious. Not just because he managed to get a Stealth Shuttle for personal use.”

“I need it for work,” the General retorted. “If I had to go through the Space Force every time I needed one, I’d never get anything done. And it’s owned by the Alliance, not me.”

Sam refrained from pointing out that he also used the Shuttle as a personal craft when it wasn’t used by his command.

“And why shouldn’t you have a personal Stealth Shuttle if you wanted one?” Entrapta asked. “It would be a gift from your friends, namely us! And refusing gifts from your friends would be rude!”

The rest of the Etherians looked as if they agreed, with the possible exception of Catra, Sam noted.

“Ah… accepting gifts is actually a bit of a problem for many people in positions of authority or power.” Daniel smiled weakly. “Or, well, it should be - and with good reason. Because accepting a gift often implies an obligation to reciprocate, and that could be problematic if they, ah, returned the favour, abusing their power.”

“Then you punish them if they do that. Problem solved,” Glimmer said. “Why would you punish someone for accepting a gift if there’s no actual corruption?”

“It’s also, ah, about the appearance of corruption,” Daniel said. “If people think you are corrupt, their trust in you and your

organisation tends to weaken."

"Wouldn't they trust their princess to check? Or is this another problem with democracy?" Entrapta asked.

Yes, their Etherian friends saw things quite differently, Sam reminded herself as Daniel continued to explain the way corruption worked on Earth. They didn't quite understand how people could think the General was corrupt just because he used a shuttle for private purposes.

*****

Cultural Exchange Part 5

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, December 5th, 1999

"...and we need to counter these accusations. This cannot stand!"

Catra snorted when Glimmer hit the table with her fist to emphasise her words. She was taking this hard, but then, she had been quite concerned about her own reputation, back during the Horde War. Back before - and after - Queen Angella had… sacrificed herself to save the world. From Catra's folly.

She pressed her lips together and tried to ignore the guilt she felt as the others continued to talk.

"They aren't accusations - not in the formal sense. It's just rumours," Daniel said.

"Then we need to counter those rumours!" Glimmer spat.

"Yes!" Adora agreed.

"Why? Let them talk. Soldiers complain about their leaders all the time," Sha're said. "What can they do? You're the Supreme Commander, Adora. Unless you turn against Jack, there is nothing Smith or anyone can do."

"Ah, that's not exactly how this works, dear," Daniel said. "Adora isn't supposed to abuse her power and protect criminals."

"I am not a criminal, Daniel."

"Well, of course not. I'm just saying Adora can't order the Alliance around like that if you *were* a criminal."

"I think that means you aren't supposed to do that," Catra commented, grinning at her lover. "You totally could do it, and

Priest and the entire Third Fleet would follow you." And that was the backbone of the Alliance at the moment.

Adora scowled at her. "I'm not going to abuse my position!" Then she blinked and smiled at Jack. "Not that protecting you from such accusations would be abusing my position since you haven't done anything wrong!"

"Nothing that not everyone else did as well," Catra added.

Everyone frowned at her. "What do you mean?" Glimmer asked. Rather sharply, in Catra's opinion.

"Using the shuttle nominally attached to his command for private purposes," Catra replied. "Apparently, you're not supposed to do that."

"Why not?" Glimmer asked. "He's in charge of the Special Operations Command. He can use the shuttle as he pleases."

"It's more efficient that way," Entrapta added. "Of course, we could give you another shuttle, but then at least one of them would always be standing around and not used since you can't use two of them at the same time. Of course, it would be a spare shuttle for emergencies…"

"Ah, I don't think adding another shuttle for Jack's personal use would help with battling the rumours of corruption," Daniel said. With a glance at Jack, he added: "Sorry."

"Don't worry, one shuttle is enough for me." Jack grinned widely.

Catra snorted, but not everyone found Jack's joke funny - Sam glared at him.

"Wait! You're not supposed to use your equipment?" Adora asked.

"They're not meant for private use," Sam told her. "Although there are exceptions for personal vehicles."

“And a shuttle is a vehicle!” Jack grinned again, but not for long. “Anyway, everyone hops on an Air Force plane if they can - it saves time and money. And if you’re a pilot, you also take any stick time you can get. But not everyone has a shuttle they can use for that.”

“General Naird was quite unhappy that his command wasn’t assigned a shuttle,” Sam added.

“And he wasn’t the only one, I bet,” Jack said. “They’re jealous.”

“So, should we hand them shuttles as well?” Entrapta asked. “It would set our projected production back a bit, but if that will solve our problem, we can do it!”

“I fear, at this point, it would be seen as an attempted bribe,” Sam objected.

“Yeah,” Jack agreed. “Once they start talking about how you shouldn’t use a shuttle like that, they can’t go back and get one of their own - well, they could, but it would make them the next target.”

“Then what can we do?” Adora asked.

“What can Wilkinson do?” Bow asked. “He’s in Washington, and Jack’s usually here or in Germany. Or in Etheria.”

“He can snoop around in Washington and ask all my fellow generals,” Jack said. “And he can hop on a plane and travel to Europe as well.”

And just dealing with the spy wasn’t on the table, Catra knew.

“But he wouldn’t have any authority in Europe - or outside the USA in general,” Daniel pointed out.

“This isn’t an authorised investigation, so he doesn’t have any authority to begin with,” Jack said.

“Ah, right.” Daniel winced. “Still, that means he is limited in what he can do.”

“Never underestimate a lone wolf. Whether it’s an assassin or a spook.” Jack bared his teeth.

Catra nodded. A single spy like Double Trouble could cause a lot of harm.

“So, what can we do?” Daniel asked.

“We could try to speak to him?” Entrapta suggested. “Explain the situation?”

“That would make him even more suspicious; I know the type,” Jack said. “He’ll already suspect foul play - you’ve heard him. He probably thinks I’ll ask some old Black Ops contacts to silence him.”

“Or us,” Catra added. She grinned. “But if he suspects foul play, what if he finds something worse than corruption? An attempt to frame a brave hero?”

Jack blinked. “You want to set him on Smith?”

Catra nodded. “We can set up Smith. Give him a taste of his own medicine.”

“Yeah, we could. It won’t be easy, but we could do that.”

“But what if Smith is honestly mistaken?” Adora asked.

“I doubt that,” Jack said.

“But we can check that first, I think,” Bow said. “Well, you can - we still have to deal with the Asgard.”

“Don’t remind me,” Glimmer muttered.

Catra grinned. She could do something interesting and avoid something boring - perfect.

*****

Above the Pentagon, Washington D.C., United States of America, December 5th, 1999

This is a waste of time, Jack O'Neill thought as he leaned back in his seat in his stealth shuttle. Smith was a four-star general - you didn't reach that rank by being naive. Or by being so honest and by the book, you couldn't tolerate the usual rules-bending by the brass. Smith's own command would have sabotaged him if he had been that kind of hardass because no one wanted to serve under such a commander.

So, Smith had to know what he was doing. But the Etherians would need more than that to use slightly less-than-honest means to deal with him. Well, most of them - Jack was sure that Catra would be fine with framing Smith for any crime. But they didn't have to go that far, anyway - Smith must have some skeletons in his closet; they only needed to find them.

But still… Jack couldn't help feeling that he was missing something. Smith wasn't dumb. Did he really expect a drummed-up charge of misuse of a service vehicle - which everyone did to some degree - to bring down Jack? Smith was aware that Jack was a close friend of Adora and the other Etherians. Too close to be hurt by such accusations - especially since the Etherians considered using his shuttle for anything perfectly fine and dandy. Hell, the government was counting on Jack and the rest of SG-1 to use their friendship to influence the Etherians, and that cut both ways.

No, even if Jack were corrupt - and he wasn't - this wouldn't be enough to get him cashiered. They needed him too much. Not just because he was friends with Princesses, of course, but also because he had the most experience fighting the snakes. And he was good at it.

So, why was Smith sending a rogue FBI agent after Jack? What did he hope to gain from this? Was he actually counting on the

disgruntled conservatives and religious nutcases to push the government into dropping Jack? The government had made it clear that it valued the Alliance far more than what influence those people had left. Even with the presidential election coming up next year, no candidate - none with a serious chance at getting a nomination in either party, at least - was campaigning on a platform that would piss off the Etherians.

Wilkinson was right that a lot of people were unhappy with the changes the Alliance with Etheria brought to the United States, but the country was in the middle of a war, and that meant people were closing ranks and rallying around the flag.

He glanced over his shoulder. "Anything?"

Carter shook her head. "No, sir. Smith hasn't left his office or called anyone since you last asked."

Which had been… fifteen minutes ago. That explained why she looked a little annoyed.

"Alright." He suppressed a sigh. Maybe he should take a nap - Catra and Melog were sleeping in their seats. In such weird positions, Jack's back hurt just from looking at them. They really were like cats in that regard.

But he couldn't sleep. He was missing something, he knew that. Why was Smith doing this? And what was he hoping to gain? A promotion? He was already a four-star general, and even - or especially - if he managed to get Jack cashiered, he wouldn't get a promotion out of it. He would have pissed off the government too much with his meddling. Unless he thought his involvement would remain a secret.

Did he? Jack frowned. Wilkinson might keep the secret. But Wilkinson alone wouldn't be enough to hurt Jack. That would need a lot of influence. So, others would have to get involved. And Smith would have to move very carefully to benefit from this. Too much caution and others would take over. Too little, and he

would be sacrificed to appease the Etherians while someone else got promoted.

Would Smith really risk that? He didn't strike Jack as reckless - quite the opposite, actually. Not a coward, but quite a bit more cautious than Jack or the Etherians. Anger or desperation might change that, but envy or spite?

No, there was something else. Someone else was involved. Which, Jack admitted to himself with a grin, means that this isn't a waste of time.

If only Smith would copy Wilkinson and invite a co-conspirator over. Or start monologuing in his office! But it seemed Smith didn't want to cooperate with this investigation.

Well, Jack already knew the guy wasn't an idiot. Then again, Smith was picking a fight with Jack and his friends, and that was a really dumb move.

Something Jack was looking forward to demonstrating.

*****

Factory Complex, Scorpion Kingdom, Etheria, December 5th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and these are our bot factories. They used to produce bots for the war, then we - well, Entrapta and Hordak - repurposed them for agricultural bots, but now they're producing war bots again. And spy bots." Scorpia pointed with her pincers at a massive and - to Adora, at least - familiar factory complex.

Sure, they had prettied it up - and, more importantly, cleaned it up; it wasn't leaking acid into the water any more, and they had better filters for the exhaust pipes, as Entrapta had explained - but underneath that, it was still the same factory Adora and Catra had climbed as cadets. She could see the very spot they used to watch the Fright Zone from here. Ah… She was smiling widely, she

realised, and quickly schooled her features. This was a diplomatic event!

"You switched from agricultural equipment to arms?" Thor asked. "How did that impact your food production?"

"Not at all," Scorpia replied. "Well, not much - Perfuma worked on the plants we use so they produce more for less work." She beamed at Perfuma, who blushed a little, Adora noticed.

"I only changed the rate at which they absorbed sunlight and the efficiency of their chlorophyll. And I made them a bit more resistant to pests - not too much, or that would have meant they couldn't be cooked in the traditional way," Perfuma explained.

"Well, we could have just used them to produce Horde rations, but those factories were dismantled entirely," Scorpia said. "I kind of miss them, from time to time."

Adora stared at her friend. She missed the Horde rations? After tasting real food? Unbelievable!

Glimmer looked like she was feeling sick, and Bow grimaced. Perfuma, though, smiled at her lover.

"You ended your capability to produce rations for your soldiers?" Thor sounded incredulous as well. "In the middle of a war?"

"We did that before we knew about the Goa'uld. And only once we had better food to disperse," Perfuma said, sounding defensive.

"And if we tried to feed those rations to our soldiers, they'd probably revolt!" Scorpia chuckled. "Anyway, that's about it for our kingdom's factories. We mostly rely on Horde designs for weapons, though Entrapta has improved the models since the war."

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta piped up. "I had so many ideas I couldn't try out during the war because Hordak said the loss of production

would be worse than the gain of capability, but with the war over, I could implement them. Some of them, at least. And now, they can be field tested!”

Adora winced a bit at the enthusiasm her friend showed at this prospect. She knew Entrapta didn’t think that the war against the Goa’uld was a good thing - well, defeating them and liberating their slaves was a very good thing - but the way she talked made her sound like she did.

But the Asgard didn’t seem to react to that as they looked at the factories.

“You make heavy use of bots, then?” Thor asked.

“Oh, yes,” Scorpia said. “Bots can be repaired and replaced - most of them,” she added with a glance at Emily, “while people can’t.”

The Asard exchanged glances. “But you also field artificial intelligences.” Penegal cocked his head. “What do they think of this?” He wasn’t looking at Emily directly but glanced in her direction.

Emily beeped.

“Emily knows that we need to free the slaves of the Goa’uld,” Entrapta translated. “And she also knows we can replace the dumb bots.”

“So, they are willing to risk their existence for the war?” Penegal asked.

“Yes?” Entrapta looked puzzled.

“Everyone is aware of the need to defeat the Goauld,” Perfuma said. “Though we won’t force people to fight them if they don’t want to. But we learned harsh lessons during the Horde War.” She looked at the factory complex. “And we’re going to do things better in this war. We won’t make the same mistakes.”

If Catra were here, she'd say that they were going to make all-new mistakes. But she wasn't. Adora cleared her throat in the sudden silence. "Anyway, this is where most of the weapon production on Etheria happens," she said. "We've adapted the former Horde factories." And staffed them with former Horde soldiers.

"And you're showing us your key weapon factories?" Thor turned his head a bit to glance at the factories again.

"Yes?" Entrapta looked confused again. "Why wouldn't we?"

"It's not as if we have something to hide here," Scorpia added.

"Aha." Thor didn't seem very impressed, though. Well, the backbone of Etheria's military in this war were the Horde fleets, and those were built and maintained in space, which the Asgard would know.

Freyr, who hadn't said much so far, suddenly addressed Perfuma. "You mentioned adapting the plants you grow for food. As I understand, you used magic for it. How exactly did you do that?"

Perfuma perked up. "Oh, let me show you!" She spread her hands, and vines grew out of the ground, quickly sprouting colourful fruits. "I altered the fruits, for example, to be more efficient and less appealing to the birds that usually eat them, so we need fewer people to tend to them. Then I spread the plants." She smiled. "I also altered the colour of the fruits, but that was just for variety." As she spoke, the fruits changed colours back and forth.

The Asgard were staring. At the plants and at Perfuma.

"Genetic manipulation on such a level…"

"And at that speed!"

"Without any tools at all. Pure magic."

Adora wasn't quite sure if their reaction was a good thing or not.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, December 5th, 1999

I might be getting a bit too comfortable with this, Samantha Carter thought as she ran another search algorithm on files she officially didn't have access to but could easily download with a bit of effort that could barely be called hacking. Being involved, and in a significant position, with building the Alliance computer network had its perks.

But the General was correct - too much about this case didn't make enough sense to dismiss the possibility of an outside element influencing or manipulating Smith. And since Adora had signed off on the investigation, it was legal anyway. Only technically, though, and only because of the Etherians' influence on the Alliance regulations - NATO regulations wouldn't have allowed such interference on the Supreme Commander's say so. And whether that authorised her to break into civilian databanks without a warrant by a judge was unclear.

She didn't expect much from this particular data analysis, anyway. Smith hadn't been very active in Brussels. The man had done a stint at NATO headquarters, but it hadn't been anything more than another mark in his file to push his career at the Pentagon. And when he got his new post with the Alliance, he hadn't even bothered with getting a flat in Brussels despite having an office here.

With someone else, that might have been explained by caring too much about his home and family in Washington D.C. to bother setting up a new home here, but Smith wasn't spending enough time with his family. Sam wouldn't call him a workaholic, but only because the man still didn't work quite as much as she did, and she wasn't a workaholic either; she merely had a sound sense of priorities.

On the other hand, she would have expected Smith to focus on his career in the Alliance. He should have realised that the most important decisions were being made here, not in the Pentagon or Washington.

Shaking her head at the inconsistencies, she checked the computer. Almost done. And Catra had already finished bugging Smith's office here. Sam didn't expect much from that either, but you had to cover all bases in such an investigation. Literally, in some cases. At least Smith had been posted to the Pentagon for the last few years, or they would have had to investigate even more places. If Sam had to root through another inefficiently organised computer system just to…

A beep interrupted her thoughts. Her algorithm had flagged something… no. It was from the stealth bot monitoring Wilkinson. The man was moving.

"What's happening?" Catra walked over. Apparently, the noise had caught her interest.

"Wilkinson is leaving his office," Sam told her.

"With Paris?"

"No. He seems to be alone. He might be going for a lunch." According to his filed expenses, the man liked to eat out.

"Hm. Good idea. It's lunchtime there - and dinner time here."

Sam raised her eyebrows at her. Catra thought about eating while their suspect was moving?

The other woman flashed her a wide grin. "Do you want something as well?"

"Are you going to Noordzee again?" Sam asked.

"Of course!"

The place didn’t have a constant menu, but they always had fresh seafood. And trying to get Catra to go somewhere else was an exercise in futility. And often frustration. “Get me a sandwich.”

“Alright.” Catra got up and left their office.

Sam checked her computer again. Wilkinson was still driving. He had passed his favourite diner already. She quickly ran a short check on his expenses. There wasn’t another restaurant in that direction that he had frequented in the last year. She brought up Smith’s data. No, nothing there either - and Smith hadn’t left the Pentagon.

A few minutes later, she watched Wilkinson’s car park next to an old Italian restaurant. If the General were here, he’d make a joke about the mob, but this didn’t have to mean anything. Odds were, the food wasn’t even authentic Italian.

The stealth bot flew a bit down to get a better line of sight into the restaurant. Wilkinson didn’t take a table at a window - he was headed to the back. If he entered a private room… No, he sat down at the bar, gesturing to the bartender.

The bot’s sensors were good but not good enough to listen in from that distance. But the mirror behind the bar meant Wilkinson’s face was visible.

Sam wasn’t a lip-reader, but she had a program for that. A few clicks got it up and running on the feed from the bot.

“… Pastrami?”

“Yes. And a coke.”

Well, that wasn’t a very important conversation. Sam shook her head with a smile.

Then another man sat down at the bar, next to Wilkinson. And they looked at each other in the mirror, Sam noticed. She ran a

search for a match for his face while he ordered a sandwich as well.

"What do you have for me?"

"You're being used."

"Tell me something new."

"Your source has contacts with us."

"Again, tell me something new."

"The kind of contacts that involve the kind of business you hate."

"Is he involved?"

"Hard to say. But someone's covering up whatever he is involved in."

"Can you uncover it?"

"Not without risking more trouble than this is worth."

"I see."

Sam frowned. What did that mean? Were they talking about the General? Or Smith? Smith was Wilkinson's source, wasn't he?

Her laptop beeped again. She had a match for the other man. Oh. Kevin Miller. CIA.

Things got just a little bit more complicated.

*****

Langley, Virginia, United States of America, December 5th, 1999

A whole building full of spies! Catra grinned as she studied the CIA headquarters on her screen. "I can't believe that's just one of

your spy agencies."

"We're a big country," Jack replied.

"And you spy on everyone. Even yourselves."

"As this mission demonstrates, we got reasons for that."

She snorted at that without taking her eyes off the target. "Now, this is a challenge."

"The FBI wasn't?"

"They're not really spies," she told him. "They're cops who also hunt spies. But the CIA? All spies. And it takes a spy to hunt a spy."

"I think the FBI disagrees."

"Of course they would. But we infiltrated their headquarters easily. This, though…?"

"We do not need to infiltrate their headquarters," Sam commented from her seat. "We just need access to their data."

"For which we need to sneak into the building." Catra grinned again.

Challenge.

"Melog agrees," she added.

"The FBI has a magic program. The CIA undoubtedly has one as well," Sam pointed out. "You will have to deal with this."

Of course, they would. But they weren't facing experienced sorceresses. Hell, the FBI witch hadn't even known what her spells would do. The CIA ones would be a bit better - they would probably not shy away from testing their spells against evil magic, according to everything Catra had heard about the CIA - but they were still beginners. And Catra had spent years fighting princesses

and sorceresses trained at Mystacor while Melog was, well, Melog. “We can do this.” All they had to do was to sneak in and get into Miller’s office and his computer.

“Don’t get caught,” Jack said. He sounded as if he wanted to sneak in as well.

“I won’t.”

“Scans still show no advanced technology,” Sam reported.

“And that’s suspicious,” Jack repeated himself. “If anyone should have managed to get some of the good stuff for themselves, it’s the CIA.”

“They would be aware that we can detect such technology, sir.”

“Won’t stop them.”

They had gone over his before. Catra shook her head. “Let’s go. It’s almost midnight here.” Not that that bothered her - she could nap whenever she wanted on this mission - but close to midnight on a Sunday meant the building would have the least number of spies in it.

“Alright.”

She grinned and walked to the shuttle’s back, followed by Melog. Just hovering over the building and rappelling down, like they had done with the FBI, was out. The CIA had improved the security on their roof - and on their office windows. Not with advanced technology, and not with magic, according to Melog, but the sensors they had were annoying enough. Unlike the FBI, the CIA had not ignored how they had broken into Iran’s prisons. Or the CIA was just more concerned about their own allies breaking into their building than the FBI.

It didn’t matter. They were using another way into the building anyway.

Ready.

Catra nodded. “Melog has the illusion up. Drop the ramp.”

The ramp started to lower with a very faint hissing sound, and Catra sniffed the air. Langley wasn’t as bad as the Fright Zone had been, but it was bad enough. And the sewers - or storm drains, as Sam called them - would be worse.

She pulled a mask on as she stepped out of the shuttle, then quickly rushed over to the grate covering a shaft leading down.

Stinks.

“Yeah, I know.”

But she had smelt worse. The Horde hadn’t really bothered with environmental regulations. She grabbed the grate and easily lifted it up. A moment later, Melog, changed into a slinkier form, sneaked past her and vanished down the shaft.

Clear.

She followed, closing the grate behind her. With the mask, she could ignore the smell of rotting matter. She would still need a long shower after this - the smell would linger otherwise, and to imagine her fur having even a hint of this…

She shuddered as she quickly followed Melog, back in catform, down the tunnel. A few sensors were easily fooled by illusions, and the sensors covering the exits were not a challenge either if you were used to dealing with Horde and Alliance security. The CIA apparently hadn’t gotten around to covering the underground areas as well as they had covered the roof and windows.

And now they were inside the complex. Not yet inside the target building, but close enough. And past the guards who might or might not have been sorceresses and their dogs.

She recalled the layout of the place and quickly made her way over to the building Miller was working in. The security there was a bit trickier, but Sam had her back. All Catra had to do was climb a wall until she could stick a device to the sensor covering the entrance, and Sam would hack the whole system.

Easy. They just had to…

Catra froze for a moment, her ears swivelling as she caught steps headed their way. So close to the last patrol? It seemed the CIA took care to have their guards actually patrol at random.

Dog.

And they had a dog with them! Catra hissed under her breath. "Come on!" she whispered, then quickly climbed the wall again, with Melog hanging on her shoulders.

From a windowsill on the second floor, still covered by an illusion, she watched while a guard with a damn dog walked past on the ground below. The animal even seemed to catch her scent, but a quick illusion of a squirrel dashing past distracted the dog and made the handler curse.

By the time the patrol had gone to the next building - actually random patrol patterns were a pain to deal with - Sam had dealt with the security, and Catra and Melog slipped into the building with no one the wiser.

But halfway to Miller's office, her hackles rose. Someone - no, *something* - was nearby. She could hear faint steps. Very faint steps. And she felt the temperature drop a little.

Magic.

The CIA seemed to be a bit more ahead of the FBI than Catra had thought.

"Back!" she hissed - even though Melog would already know what she was doing - and whirled around, quickly darting past two

closed doors to the corner behind them. Rounding it, she glanced at the rows of doors there, ears twitching. She hadn't heard anything on the way past them, so they should be empty. But if whoever - or whatever - was coming had a magical way to check through doors, they would be spotted anyway. Risk it?

No.

She nodded, and they kept running. She had to remind herself to keep her claws sheathed, so she didn't make any sound - or leave scratches and gouges on the floor. It was much easier to run all out with her claws digging into the ground.

Another corner. She remembered the layout. Stairs to the right, lift to the left. And around the next corner was a little nook with a window that was too small to keep the stench of cigarette smoke from lingering and seeping into the plaster.

But it was big enough for Catra, and Sam had dealt with the sensors covering the windows at the source. She opened it, hopped on the windowsill, then turned around. "Go on!"

Melog flowed past her, changing shape to avoid jostling her, while she fixed a small thread to the window's frame. A moment later, she jumped, grabbing the edge of the roof above them, then pulled the window closed with thread.

Normally, she would have slid onto the roof, but the sensors there were still working. So she had to wait, hanging from the roof, until the coast was clear again.

Melog changed shape again, this time into a snake.

Hold you.

She didn't need his help. Hanging from a branch had been standard training - and punishment - back as a cadet; she could do this all day long. Almost. She slid onto their back anyway.

Magic close.

She shouldn’t be doing this, but…

Scoffing, she bent down until she could spy through the window. She heard the steps clearly, coming closer, but there was nothing. Then she felt a cold shiver run down her spine - and saw the small window fog over slightly.

A moment later, she had pulled herself up.

Magic.

“Earth magic,” she whispered. “That’s not a human patrol.”

The CIA had summoned a spirit or something to patrol their headquarters.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, December 6th, 1999

“...and then we waited a bit longer and went back inside. Miller’s office is bugged, and Sam is already hacking his data.”

Jack O’Neill nodded. Catra might make a point of slouching so much that she looked as if she’d flow off her seat any moment, but her report was concise and to the point - as good or better than he was used to from his own people. And she didn’t make him feel guilty for involving them in a slightly illegal mission. “So, the CIA got ahead of the FBI. Probably recruited outside talent.”

“To guard their headquarters?” Catra shook her head. “That doesn’t sound like a good idea.”

“The spooks aren’t nearly as smart as they think they are,” Jack agreed. That didn’t mean they were dumb, of course, even if some were. But recruiting sources and turning spies was one thing, trusting the security of your headquarters to some hired help was another. And God help the spooks if they tried to get

some leverage on a sorceress while they were still hurting for magical assets.

"And they're competing with the Alliance for recruitment," Catra added.

"That, too." Jack nodded again. The Alliance needed every sorceress they could get. And while not every sorceress who would get hired by the CIA would be a good fit for the Alliance, Jack knew that the overlap between the requirements for his command and the CIA was considerable.

"So, gonna squeal on them? I bet they kept their magic program hidden from your government." Catra grinned. "Sam would have found it otherwise."

Jack made a noncommittal noise. Of course, Carter would have found it, but admitting even in private that you thought your Second-in-Command hacked the government wasn't something you made a habit of. "Well, I'll think about it. We would have to explain how we found out about the CIA's spooky spirit program." Oh, damn - he missed an opportunity to make a spooky spook joke. Well, Carter wasn't here, so he could use the line on her later. Although it was early morning here in Brussels already, and he had stayed up the entire night…

"Right."

"And the CIA might have kept it off the official records, but I bet the NID knows about it. And that means Kinsey knows about it. And since the man is so tight with the president…"

"Ah, yes. Democracy at work." Catra nodded with a sage expression that was obviously faked.

Jack snorted in return. "Anyway, we need to…"

A beep on his computer interrupted him.

“Huh?” That wasn’t a mail announcement. That was… an alert from Carter. “Someone’s hacking into Smith’s computer. Someone else, I mean.”

“Oh?” Catra cocked her head, then grinned.

She probably thought this was getting more interesting. Well, she wasn’t wrong. But Jack would prefer things to get boring instead.

*****

A few coffees - Navy style, but Jack would bite his tongue off before acknowledging that to anyone - later, he was talking to Carter and trying to act as if he had any clue what the stuff on her screen meant. “So, what do you have for us?”

“I’m tracking the intruder. They have tried to obfuscate their location, but their tools, while good, are no match for ours.”

“Ah.” That was… good. Jack stifled a yawn and took another sip from his coffee. “Any idea who they are?”

“This cannot be said with any certainty at this point, sir.”

He grinned. “So, you have a pretty good guess.”

For a moment, her mouth twisted into the hint of a pout. “They are using exploits that have been fixed in the Alliance systems and are scheduled to be fixed in the Pentagon systems next week. Highly-classified ones.”

“Ah. Definitely the NID, then.” Wilkinson didn’t have that kind of resources.

“Or any other agency or person with access to this information,” Carter pointed out.

He shrugged, then finished his cup of coffee. “And how many of them would hack a general’s computer in the Pentagon? That’s illegal!”

She frowned at that. Right. Right, they were doing it as well. “The CIA?”

He snorted as he nodded. “Good point. But I still say it’s the NID.”

She tilted her head in what he knew was cautious agreement.

“So!” he went on, putting his cup down on her desk. “The NID is snooping around. Did you find out what they were looking for?”

“They downloaded the entire content of his private computer, sir.”

And Smith was too smart to keep anything classified there, which the NID would know. They weren’t going for military secrets, then. Of course, with Kinsey having the president’s trust, they didn’t need to break the law for that. “Blackmail?”

“It would have been unsuccessful then.”

Carter hadn’t found anything in Smith’s files either. Although, sometimes, innocent information turned into compromising material when combined with something else. He blinked as he had another thought. “Did they plant anything?”

“No, sir.”

He caught the unspoken ‘I would have noticed and told you that already, sir’ clearly despite the late or early hour. “Right.”

Her computer decided that the slightly awkward silence that followed was the perfect moment to announce something. The numbers that appeared on the screen meant garbage to Jack, but Carter perked up. “Oh! The trace went through. The hacker is located at…” Her fingers flew over the keyboard, and a map appeared. “...here.”

He could read maps in his sleep. “Washington D.C. Not Kinsey’s address, though?”

“No, sir. Redirecting the spy bot for a close look.”

Right. If they'd had such bots during the Cold War… Real-time recon on demand, without risking anyone, was a game changer. A few minutes later, they were looking at a house so average and devoid of anything unique, it almost seemed to stick out even in its boring suburban neighbourhood.

"I think we found a NID safehouse," Jack said.

"If this is a NID operation, sir. We haven't confirmed that yet."

"No, we haven't." He grinned. "But I'm betting a month's supply of jello that I'm right."

"I'm not taking that bet," Carter replied. She waited just a moment before adding: "I have no interest in jello."

He snorted, then had to stifle another yawn. "Anyway, go to bed now. We've got a long day ahead of us. And it's a Monday to boot."

"Technically, it's already Monday here, sir."

His chuckle turned into a yawn, and he could feel her raised eyebrows on him without having to look at her.

Damn, the Navy pukes couldn't even brew their coffee right any more. No wonder their ship-building program was lagging behind the Limeys' so much.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, December 6th, 1999

"Good morning, General!"

Jack O'Neill narrowed his eyes at Lt. Brown's dig. It was past noon, but he had gone to bed at half past six in the morning, and only if you counted napping in a shuttle flying on autopilot. But saying anything would acknowledge a hit. So he nodded at his

aide. “Good morning, Brown. Anything urgent?” His communicator would have woken him up if anything had come up, but old habits died slowly.

“Senator Kinsey called, sir.”

Jack tensed. Kinsey? “He did? What was it about?”

“He didn’t say, sir. Just that it was important but that he could wait until you were in the office.”

Jack silently cursed. The NID hacking last night, and now Kinsey was calling him? The timing wasn’t suspicious, it was obvious!

And he had a bad feeling about it.

*****

Cultural Exchange Part 6

Royal Palace, Kingdom of Salineas, Etheria, December 6th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Ugh. Giving a demonstration like a trained pet. This is so annoying."

"But think of the opportunity to impress guests from another planet, my love! Another planet that's not Earth, I mean! Anyway, I've prepared a medley of my best sea shanties for this occasion, which will be the perfect accompaniment for your performance!"

"Don't try to steal the spotlight!"

"I would never do that to you, my love!"

Adora couldn't help sighing a little as she watched Mermista and Sea Hawk.

"I don't know why she keeps this up; no one believes her act, anyway," Glimmer muttered next to her. "She loves to show off."

Adora wasn't quite sure about that. Mermista was a bit grumpy at times. And she had a temper - like the sea, Sea Hawk had said once. And that this was one of the countless reasons he loved her and had never given up courting her.

Which was quite romantic, actually. But they were on a schedule. "I think we should proceed with the demonstration of your power," she told Mermista. "Sea Hawk can present his shanties after dinner."

"Oh, yes - when everyone's fed and content!" Sea Hawk nodded with a smile.

And Mermista shrugged, which counted as agreement as well.

"Let's go join our guests, then," Glimmer said.

“Our guests? We’re in my kingdom.”

“You know what I mean.”

“Whatever.”

Adora briefly, very briefly, rolled her eyes - it wasn’t fair to be annoyed at her friends; this visit was proving to be more stressful than expected, and the whole plot against Jack on Earth wasn’t helping. Nor that Catra was so busy with it. She hadn’t come back until the morning, shortly before Adora had to get ready for the visit to Salineas, and so they hadn’t been able to do much else but kiss and hug.

And then Catra had gone to bed, and Adora had gone to Salienas. Fortunately, they had taken the scenic route in a shuttle, flying at low altitude over the sea, and so the Asgard’s reaction to seeing sailing ships plying the ocean’s trade routes had not been overheard by Mermista. For a diplomatic delegation from an old species, the Asgard could be rather blunt. Adora didn’t think there was anything wrong with using magic and sails together. Or magitech and sails. Weren’t the Asgard supposed to be very traditional?

They stepped out of the palace and onto the mole sheltering the private harbour of the queen of Salineas, where the Asgard were waiting with the others.

“...and I had plans for the Horde frigates as well, to make them fly instead of float, but Hordak reminded me that if we wanted flying transport and warships, we might as well go all the way and make spaceships - only, we had a fleet already, and if I constructed a new ship for us, Darla might get jealous,” Entrapta explained, hair and arms waving around.

“You won’t design new ships because your old ones might get jealous?” Thor sounded doubtful - and a little bit shocked - in Adora’s opinion.

“Well… she was abandoned and buried in the Crimson Waste for so long, I don’t want her to worry that we would replace her - which we would never do! I can keep her upgraded so she can match any modern ship. Well, any modern ship we know, and in her class. She wouldn’t be able to match a battleship, would she?”

“With enough of a technological advantage, yes, she would,” Hordak said.

“Oh, right.”

It looked like they would have to keep an eye on Entrapta again so she wouldn’t neglect either crucial projects or her health so she could build more upgrades for Darla, Adora noted. But that could wait until this visit was over. “Sorry for the wait,” she told the group. “Something came up.”

“Yeah, yeah,” Mermista added, nodding at their guests. “So, you’re interested in my magic.”

“Yes, we are,” Freyr replied.

They were here so the Asgard could enjoy Salineas’s culture. Adora almost said something about it, but Mermista had already turned away and was facing the sea.

“So, take a good look.” She raised her trident, then gestured with it, and a huge wave suddenly rose from the sea. Higher than the masts of the ships in the main harbour. That was… more than Adora had expected. She knew Mermista could do this, but her friend rarely did that outside emergencies.

“Someone prepared for this,” Glimmer mumbled. “And she acts as if she didn’t want to show off?”

“Ah, my love - the Queen of the Seven Seas!” Sea Hawk put a hand over his heart and raised his chin as the wave slowly moved closer, then turned around its own axis, barely missing the mole.

Mermista grinned, then jumped into the sea, startling the Asgard - and even more when she emerged, her legs having turned into a fishtail, and rode the wave all across the harbour, then out to the sea.

"Telekinetic control over liquid on such a scale!"

"And the ability to manipulate her own body to transform into a hybrid life form!"

Well, the Asgard were impressed, Adora told herself.

"Now we just have to make sure Sea Hawk's shanties won't mortally insult the Asgard, and this trip wasn't a waste," Glimmer commented while they watched Mermista show off more of her powers.

Adora nodded, though she didn't think that was likely. Not after sitting through their best epic before. Sea Hawk was a master performer compared to that.

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 6th, 1999

Being healed by She-Ra when she was channelling the magic of an entire planet wasn't quite a rejuvenation treatment, but it came close. Samantha Carter had felt a lot younger ever since that moment on Saqarra. Although, as she was reminded today again, feeling younger didn't mean she was actually twenty again. At the age of twenty, she had been able to work through the night without feeling it in the morning.

Or, she amended her thoughts as she stepped out of the shuttle that had brought her to Stargate Command, maybe she hadn't been old enough to realise that her efficiency had been affected by lack of sleep. It wasn't as if most of the tests at the Air Force Academy had been too challenging.

“Major Carter.” General Hammond himself was there in the hangar, greeting her. “We’re happy you found the time to come.”

Was that a trace of resentment? And if so, was it aimed at her or at the fact that he was stuck at Stargate Command and hadn’t been transferred to Alliance headquarters? Sam couldn’t tell. “Of course, I’d make the time, sir,” she answered, stifling a yawn. She’d had almost five hours of sleep, she reminded herself - she shouldn’t be so tired.

“Well, I am glad it’s not my command that’s keeping you awake until the morning any more,” General Hammond flashed her a wry smile.

She returned the smile. Of course, he’d see through her act - he knew her almost as well as the General did. “Needs must,” she said. “But I don’t make a habit of it.”

The General would have made a joke about Sam only doing it every second night, but Hammond merely nodded. “Anyway, we’re glad you came. Dr Gregorovich tried his best, but he couldn’t solve the issue with the Stargate central computer program.”

Sam frowned. She had documented the code and written a user and maintenance manual for the entire system before she had transferred to the Alliance - precisely because she wouldn’t have the time to run back to Stargate Command to solve every issue that cropped up. Or shouldn’t have the time - the Stargate was crucial for the Alliance, so fixing any issues with it took priority even over the latest problem. She wouldn’t have left the General face Kinsey by himself, otherwise. But, still! Iwan could read English perfectly fine, his accent notwithstanding! “And what about the other scientists?”

“They couldn’t solve the issue either.” General Hammond nodded at the guard at the lift, who stood at attention as they entered. “To their great chagrin, as General Petit put it.”

She eyed the general with slightly narrowed eyes. Was that a pun? Or was she imagining things? She focused on the task at hand. “So, none have found the reason why dialling an address suddenly takes longer than it should? Did anyone look for a mechanical defect yet?”

“Yes. The gate itself is not affected.”

Of course, they would have checked that. Still, Sam had to ask - sometimes, people overlooked the most simple cause for a problem. She nodded. “So, not a hardware problem.”

“Not as far as we know.”

Oh. General Hammond was being a bit too… bland. Sam narrowed her eyes again. “Did Iwan ask for my assistance?”

“Yes, he did. General Sidorov and General Li wanted him to keep trying, but he insisted that he had tried everything to fix it.”

That sly Russian - a quarter Welsh - scientist! Sam was pretty sure he knew far more about what was wrong with the Stargate Command computer than he had let on. And he wanted her to find it. And that meant this wasn’t a computer problem.

This was a security problem. And a political problem.

“I’m a scientist,” she muttered under her breath.

“Pardon?” General Hammond turned to look at her right when the doors opened.

“Nothing, sir.”

Just an overdose of politics, she heard the General comment in the back of her mind.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, December 6th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra smiled as she approached the Stargate. It was afternoon, and she had spent the entire day in bed while everyone else was dealing with the Asgard. And with the grumpy water princess. Sure, Catra had worked through the night before, but that had been while infiltrating a spy headquarters and hunting traitors - interesting, not boring. Or annoying.

And now, it was time to head back to Earth and check up on the plot against Jack. And avoid more paperwork.

Work waiting.

She snorted, tilting her head to raise her eyebrows at Melog. "It's not the same."

Same.

She snorted again. "It's not." If it was interesting, it wasn't really work. Earth had a saying about that.

Melog radiated some smugness in return.

The guards at the Stargate didn't even twitch; they were used to them communicating like that. The officer in charge nodded at her while the Stargate started to rise. "To Earth?"

Where else would she be going? She had been doing that trip every day for a while now. She nodded instead of pointing that out; better to stick to procedure than to let the gate crew get used to anticipating any requests. That could really mess up things in the worst moments.

The Stargate started spinning a few moments later, followed by the vortex extending and collapsing. Catra suppressed the slight unease she felt as she approached the stabilised wormhole. If there was a mistake, or sabotage, she would end up splattered against the iris at Stargate command at lightspeed or something.

She had to trust that this wouldn't happen. Had to trust the people at Stargate Command. And all the stories she had heard from Jack and the others made that a bit difficult. All those crises…

Well, they hadn't messed up in that way. Not so far. She nodded at the guards and stepped through.

A disturbing but also thrilling moment later, Melog and Catra stepped into Stargate Command on Earth. "Hi, everyone!" She waved with a grin - but narrowed her eyes when she spotted Sam in the control room, bent over the console there, with the Russian scientists next to her and Hammond and the Russian general hovering a bit behind.

"I think something's not right here," she muttered. Sam wasn't assigned to Stargate Command any more. And she had better things to do, many more, than helping out her old command - unless she was urgently needed here for another crisis.

Yes. Problem, Melog agreed.

"Then let's see what the problem is - and what we can do about it," she said. Turning to the Gate guards, she added: "We're going to meet Major Carter." She flashed her fangs to make sure the men knew this wasn't a request.

A minute later, they entered the command room. "Hi, Sam! Hello, General Hammond. Dr Gregorovich. Everyone else."

They were expecting her. "Catra." Hammond nodded at her. "Melog."

"Miss Catra! Melog! Welcome to humble abode!" Gregorovich smiled at her.

Sidorov, of course, glared. The man didn't like to be lumped in with everyone else. Which was why Catra had done it.

“So, what’s wrong this time?” she asked, hopping up to sit on the console next to Sam’s.

“We’re dealing with a computer problem,” Sam explained. “The core unit doesn’t perform to spec.”

“Da! Half as fast as it should be,” Gregorovich added.

“It isn’t quite that bad,” Sam corrected him. “But it’s still a noticeable drop in performance.”

“Someone messed with your code?” Catra asked. It would have been stupid, but people were stupid. Even the smart ones. Or especially the smart ones. Many of them just couldn’t let things be as long as they worked. If someone had tried to improve the computer and messed up…

“The core programs are working fine. We’re checking the subroutines now, then the peripherals.”

Catra wasn’t a computer expert - Entrapta and Bow handled that stuff - but she had kept up with the basics when she had led the Horde. If they were checking every part of the system… “No documented changes, I guess.”

“No.” Sam frowned.

“And no one admitted extra work.” Gregorovich shook his head. “Not even after we say that no gulag waiting for them for mistake.”

Catra snorted, though it might not be a joke. Or a mistake. Sidorov hadn’t commented yet, she noticed. The Russian was glaring at everyone, especially Gregorovich, though.

And wasn’t that interesting? She grinned.

Then her ears twitched when Sam’s computer beeped. She knew that kind of alert - it had found something.

Sam dropped all pretence that she had been paying attention to their talk and focused on her screen. "Ah! The peripherals have undocumented activity showing." Her fingers flew over the keyboard. Another beep. Different tone. "And there just was an attempt to access my computer."

"A hacker?" Hammond asked.

"More like a virus, sir." Sam looked up with a grim expression. "Someone infected the Stargate computers with malware."

Catra hissed under her breath. Sabotage. Or spying. Or both. If that virus had gotten to the controls for the iris in mid-transit… She glanced at Sidorov. He was tense, but everyone was.

Afraid.

Catra bared her teeth in a grin. Infecting the Stargate computers wasn't easy. Sam and Entrapta had done the security; the core computer and its peripherals weren't connected to the outside. So, it had to be an inside job.

And Catra was sure she knew who was responsible.

Hammond was still cursing under his breath. "Can you remove the virus?"

"Yes, sir. But it will take a while. And we should shut down the Stargate until we've purged the systems."

"Da. Better safe than sorry, right?"

Catra nodded in agreement. "And we need to find the traitor behind this," she added.

Sidorov tensed up even more.

*****

Capitol, Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, December 6th, 1999

"Thank you for coming to see me on such a short notice, General O'Neill. Even for a Senator, getting a flight on short notice so close to the Holidays would have been a hassle, and some things shouldn't be trusted to a phone call."

Jack O'Neill was pretty sure that Kinsey was lying. The first clue was that the man was talking. But Jack was also sure that Kinsey wouldn't have any problems getting a flight, even if it were Christmas Eve. "It was no trouble," he replied, leaning back in his seat.

"Ah, yes - I heard about your personal shuttle." Kinsey smiled almost wistfully. "It's remarkably convenient. I don't think even the President has a shuttle at his disposal like that."

Jack narrowed his eyes at the man as his polite smile faded. "It's assigned to my command. When it's not needed for combat missions or training, it serves as transportation." He managed to close his mouth before he added a comment about Kinsey's office being much nicer than his own. Even if it was true - the scumbag probably had lots of equally corrupt visitors to cater to.

"Of course. I'm sure all the i's are dotted, and the t's are crossed." Kinsey's smile wasn't as patronising as it usually was when the guy thought he had the upper hand, but he couldn't hide his attitude completely.

Jack nodded. "Of course. I've got nothing to hide." He made a point of glancing around the senator's office.

Kinsey was unfazed. "Of course not. Although in politics, appearances matter as much - or more - than facts." He put his elbows on his desk and laced his fingers

Jack shrugged. "You would know. I'm a soldier, not a politician."

“Isn’t there a saying that war was just the continuation of politics by other means?” Kinsey asked.

“Clausewitz.” His exact quote was a bit different, but that was the gist. “But he didn’t mean for soldiers to make politics.” Well, maybe he had meant that - there was the old joke about Prussia being an army with a state, which had some grounding in facts.

“You’re a member of Alliance High Command, General. At your rank, you are involved in politics whether you admit it or not.” Kinsey’s smile grew a few teeth. “And, seeing how close you are to the Supreme Commander of the Alliance and key leaders of the senior member in the Alliance, I would say you are doing very well.”

And I bet you’re envious, Jack thought. He didn’t say that, though, but snorted instead. “That’s not politics, senator. We’re friends.”

“And friends help each other.”

Oh, for… Jack clenched his teeth for a moment. “What are you insinuating, Senator?”

Kinsey’s smile grew just a smidgen. “As I said, appearances matter in politics. You appear to be rising beyond the reach of many of your peers, General, thanks to your friendship with the Etherians.”

Jack slightly tilted his head to the side. “My peers, who cultivated the friendships of American politicians to advance their careers?” Such as yourself?

“Precisely.” Kinsey’s smile didn’t falter. “Unfortunately, some of your peers are not quite as skilled in politics as they thought they were and are misjudging their situation.”

Jack frowned. “Misjudging their situation?”

Kinsey nodded. “They - and, unfortunately, a number of my esteemed colleagues in Congress - don’t seem to understand our Etherian allies, and their actions reflect that.”

Jack nodded, wishing the man would get to the point.

Kinsey leaned back. “They act as if the princesses were American politicians, beholden to public opinion and certain standards.”

Jack snorted again. “They should attend a lecture or two of Daniel about that topic. He loves talking about the differences between Earth and Etheria.”

“Oh, yes. Dr Jackson’s lessons were very insightful. Unfortunately, many of my colleagues tend to listen to lobbyists more than to scientists.” Kinsey sighed. “Many are also too conservative to adapt to changes, even drastic, fundamental changes. But I digress.”

Yes, you do, Jack thought. You didn’t call me here to vent about your colleagues.

Kinsey leaned forward. “They don’t get that Etherians consider politics a personal affair. And they don’t get that the Etherians won’t throw a friend to the wolves to maintain appearances because they don’t have to care about appearances - at least not as far as the public is concerned.”

So that was why Kinsey hadn’t moved against him, Jack realised. A great deal made sense now. “Are you talking about General Smith?”

Kinsey nodded, his expression shifting to show satisfaction. “Of course. You’ve been aware of his attempts to slander you as corrupt for some time now.”

Kinsey made it sound as if Jack kept tabs on all potential ‘rivals’ or something. Like Kinsey surely did. Jack shrugged in response. “Not in any detail.”

"You are too modest, General. I know you've been investigating him and his contacts." Kinsey smiled, showing all his teeth. "And so have I."

And now came the offer. Jack tilted his head. "Ah."

"Yes." Kinsey nodded in that smarmy, self-satisfied manner of his. "Smith thinks that if you look like you're abusing your position, you will be relieved of your post. He's wrong, of course - even if you were abusing your position for personal gain, your friends wouldn't care. That's just how leaders in absolute monarchies act, after all. Something anyone with experiences with dictatorships on Earth should have been aware of, of course."

Jack glared at the scumbag. "Are you really comparing Adora and the other princesses to dictators, Senator?"

Kinsey nodded. "They effectively are dictators, General. Absolute monarchs. Friendly, idealistic and, as far as it looks like, benevolent ones, but they aren't beholden to anyone and not bound by any law but, possibly, outside pressure. Pressure which not even a united Earth could bring to bear at the moment."

That was… not as completely wrong as Jack would like. It was still not right, though. "And yet they are more trustworthy than anyone on Earth," he retorted. "They'll keep their word even if it costs them." As their issues with the Asgard proved.

Kinsey shrugged. "You're not exactly unbiased, General. But as long as the interests of Earth and Etheria align, I doubt that the princesses' honour will be put to the test, so to speak."

Jack pressed his lips together. As if Kinsey knew anything about honour! "I doubt that you called me to Washington just to talk about our allies'."

"Not *just* to talk about our allies, no." Kinsey smiled again. "But your relationship with the Etherians features a great deal in many talks at the highest level, General. And that means you are a person of great interest and importance to our government."

Something you no doubt hate, Jack thought - but he nodded slowly. No point in denying the obvious.

"Should anything happen to you, the repercussions would be grave and unpredictable. And that means many people keep tabs on you."

Jack snorted. "Like the NID."

"Amongst others." Kinsey didn't quite shrug but tilted his head to the side for a moment. "Not just American groups, of course - our NATO allies are aware of your influence as well, and so are Russia and China, especially with their access to Stargate Command's records. Even redacted, they reveal quite a lot about you."

"Only good things, I hope." Jack flashed a grin at Kinsey.

Kinsey's smile twisted for a moment. "That's a matter of opinion. The insights those records allow into your characters are a two-edged sword, so to speak. In more ways than one, actually - you have a history of doing what you think is right, sometimes to the point of insubordination. While your results speak for themselves, that is not a trait everyone considers admirable in a soldier, much less someone with your personal influence on the highest level of politics."

"Mindless obedience is not a trait encouraged in the US Armed Forces," Jack retorted. "That's the Goa'uld way."

"Soldiers acting independently of, or even against the will of the civilian government is not the American way either, General."

Oh, that was rich! "Neither is having secret services running out of control," Jack snapped.

Kinsey smiled in return. "Like having a team investigate General Smith and various civilians?"

Jack clenched his teeth. Can't lose my temper, he reminded himself. "Investigating potential alien infiltrations falls under the

mandate of the Alliance."

Kinsey laughed. "Oh, I have no doubt that you ensured your private investigation was authorised by the Supreme Commander. But we both know what you did - and why, General."

You think you know, Jack thought. "What do you want?"

Kinsey leaned back, smiling in that self-satisfied way as if he had just won something. "I want you to be more careful, General."

"What?" What did he mean?

"As I've said before, you are a very important person. With the possible exception of Major Carter, no one else in the Alliance, or on Earth, is as close to the leading Etherian princesses as you are. And most of them are very young, barely out of their teens. Idealistic. Passionate. And absolute monarchs in control of the most powerful member of the Alliance. Who could tell how they would react should anything happen to you?"

Was that a threat? Jack narrowed his eyes. "They're veterans. They fought in a decades-long war. They know the risks." Or should, though She-Ra's ability to heal anyone would skew that.

"Oh, yes. Combat isn't what I - and others, including the president - are worried about. No, it's attacks of a different nature against you, General."

"Like Smith, you mean."

Another smug grin. "Exactly. Appearances matter, General," Kinsey repeated himself. "If you are seen as corrupt, as abusing your position for personal gain - or to sabotage potential rivals - and the Supreme Commander of the Alliance makes it clear that you will not suffer any consequences, how will that look to the public? And to your peers in the Armed Forces?" He shook his head. "It would undermine the support for the Alliance and even the war. Not fatally, of course. Not in the middle of a war for our lives. But it will strain our relations with the Etherians and the public's trust

in our soldiers, our allies and our government. And that will affect the war."

And probably your plans, Jack thought. "Unless such detractors were revealed to be corrupt themselves."

Kinsey chuckled. "Indeed, General. Whether they actually are corrupt or not, should they be perceived as such, the whole affair would look very different, wouldn't it? And that's where we come in."

Ah. Jack forced himself not to snarl at him. "You want the NID to handle this."

"What I want is you and your friends to stop meddling in this and focus on the war. The NID is already handling this. You're a very capable officer, General, but this is not your area of expertise. And the more you meddle, the harder you make it for us to handle this and keep your reputation clean."

Jack wanted to deck the bastard. Smash his grinning teeth in. "You've been handling this for a while, have you?" he spat. That would explain why Smith thought he had the support to pull this off. And probably how the damn actor got involved. And Wilkinson… had probably been on the NID's list as a useful crusader for justice or something, perfect for this kind of plot.

Kinsey smiled. "It pays to be proactive in this business. You do your job, General, and we do ours. Everybody wins."

Until those jobs collided with each other, Jack thought. Or Kinsey would attempt to use this as leverage. But he hadn't, so far. If Jack pushed the issue, things would go as Kinsey had mentioned, only worse. And while Jack was tempted to stick it to Kinsey anyway, it wasn't worth it. Not now.

Damn.

*****

Royal Palace, Kingdom of Snows, Etheria, December 6th, 1999 (Earth Time)

The ice skating show was great, in Adora's opinion - she was clapping with a wide smile when the skaters - or would they be dancers? - showed up at the end to bow to the audience after dazzling them with jumps and stunts, performed to live music, for an hour.

"Encore!" Bow yelled. "Encore!"

"Huh?" Glimmer looked as confused as Adora felt.

"That's what they yell on Earth when they want another song at a concert," he explained.

"And do you think they know that?" Glimmer asked.

"Ah…" Bow winced. "I didn't think of that."

"Duh!"

Adora glanced around. Indeed, no one seemed to have caught Bow's meaning in the audience - and the cast of the show left the stage - or rink to applause without performing another scene.

Sighing, she glanced at the Asgard - the show had been so captivating that she had almost forgotten about them.

They had their heads stuck together and were talking. Had the show fascinated them as well? Adora hoped that was the case. Sea Hawk's shanties hadn't, unfortunately. "So, what do you think?" she asked.

"The ice that covered the stage," Freyr said. "Princess Frosta couldn't have produced so much water out of the air; we would have felt the effects. She must have magically created the water."

"Uh… yes?" Adora tilted her head and tried not to look confused.

“How long will it last?” Penegal asked.

“Normally, until it melts?” That was how it had been when Frosta had fought in the war. “But since we’re here in the Kingdom of Snows, it won’t melt unless someone heats the ice,” she added.

“By ‘melting’, do you mean ice turning into water or disappearing?” Freyr sounded very intently for such a simple question.

“Frosta’s Ice turns into water,” Glimmer told him. “It’s magically created, but otherwise works as normal ice.”

“So, she creates matter - water - out of nothing?” Thor shook his head.

“Yes?” Adora answered him anyway.

“But… that means…” Freyr seemed concerned. “You’re creating matter from magic. How does that affect the planet over time?”

Adora frowned. That was a good question, actually. Constantly adding water to Etheria over time would probably affect the climate. On the other hand… “I don’t think Frosta creates enough ice to affect the entire world,” she said.

“But if her successor inherits her power, and if her predecessors had the same power…” Freyr trailed off.

“The whole line would only be a thousand years old,” Glimmer said. “That was when the First Ones created the powers.”

The Asgard quickly nodded, but Adora was sure they would try to calculate the total amount of water Frosta and the other princesses of the Kingdom of Snows had created since the founding of the line.

She blinked, then sighed a second time. Once more, the Asgard had been focusing on the magic used in and for the show, not on

the performance of the artists. “What did you think of the show?” she asked, already suspecting the answer.

“It was rather interesting,” Freyr said, but Adora didn’t think he sounded honest.

“It was a little light on magic and magitech. I thought this was a core part of your culture,” Penegal commented.

Thor nodded. “And it was a little hard to follow the plot.”

“And when the performers moved to the back, it was hard to see what they were doing,” Penegal added.

“Yes.” Freyr nodded. “If you could play the recording as it’s being recorded on a big screen, that would probably make it easier to watch the performance.”

“It wasn’t recorded.” Frosta had arrived, and Adora winced - she must have been too distracted to notice the princess’s approach. If Catra were here, she would tease her mercilessly about it.

“It wasn’t recorded?” Thor looked surprised.

“This was a royal performance in your honour,” Frosta explained. “Recording it would have been rude.”

“So… the only recording of this performance are our memories?” Freyr shook his head.

“Exactly,” Frosta said.

“But you aren’t… You will all die one day. And the memory - the memories - will be lost. Your heirs will never know this performance.” Penegal looked at them. “Don’t you think this is a great loss?”

Bow looked a little torn about it, but Frosta shook her head without showing any doubts. “No. My successor will make their own memories.”

"That's part of our culture," Glimmer added. "Not everything is recorded for prosperity."

"But you'll lose so much…" Thor sounded as if this was the weirdest thing he had ever heard during this visit.

"And we won't get weighed down by it," Micah cut in. "We won't have to live up to our predecessors. Our performances won't be compared to those of the distant past. That's rather liberating, I think."

The Asgard didn't look as if they'd agreed, but Adora understood what he meant. And so did the others, judging by the way they smiled at Micah.

Though Adora didn't really feel like smiling - the more of Etheria they showed to the Asgard, the deeper the rift seemed to grow. And the Asgard only seemed to be interested in finding out more about magic and magitech.

She blinked. They really only seemed to care about magic. Much more than they cared about the deal with Loki, even.

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 6th, 1999

The full Stargate Command Council had been assembled before Samantha Carter had finished her examination of the last peripherals of the system. Of course, she had expected that - any commander in charge of a military installation would come running if told that their computer systems had been infiltrated.

But it did affect her attempts to complete her scans. General Hammond, of course, knew better than to bother her. And General Haig had merely asked for a short explanation and then let her work, but General Petit had offered both questions and suggestions that were neither new nor helpful and only showed that he wasn't a trained IT specialist. And Sidorov and Li…

“Are you absolutely certain that the system was hacked? After you were reassigned, other specialists took over maintenance. They might have changes you mistook for unauthorised alterations,” Li asked. Or suggested - after a few similar questions, his tone and manner had subtly shifted and now implied that Sam should ‘carefully consider’ this. At least in her impression.

“I can safely discard that possibility, General,” she replied.

“Who’s to say that you didn’t plant those programs yourself? To frame others or sabotage the Stargate program now that you aren’t in full control of its systems any more?” Sidorov glared at her, then at General Hammond. “I know NATO is just waiting for a pretext to take over Earth’s gateway to the stars!” he blustered.

“Really? Is that the best you could come up with?” Catra burst out laughing before Sam could think of a response that would let her call the Russian a paranoid liar while remaining within the bounds of proper conduct for an officer.

Sidorov rounded on her. “And what are you doing here? This does not concern aliens! This is a highly secret matter for the United Nations Security Council’s appointed task force!”

“I’m here because I was passing through when I heard that the facility we use for crucial Alliance tasks was compromised,” Catra retorted with a wide grin that showed her fangs. “So, I’m here to find out what happened - and who did try to sabotage the Stargate.”

“This is none of your business!” Sidorov snapped. “You do not have any authority here! And neither do you!” he added with a glance at Sam. “Who let an outsider access our computers, anyway?”

“I specifically called Major Carter because of performance issues with our systems which she, as the one most familiar with our computers, would be most likely to solve,” General Hammond spoke up. “You were aware of that, General.”

“Da!” Iwan nodded. “It was my recommendation - Sam is best specialist for computers here we know.”

Judging by the glare Sidorov sent at him, Sam expected Iwan to ask for asylum in the West - or on Etheria - after this so he didn’t end up in a gulag. There weren’t supposed to be any gulags left in Russia, but Russia also wasn’t supposed to bug Stargate Command’s system, and while Sam hadn’t proof of the latter, she was sure that Sidorov was involved - and Li as well.

And she really doubted that either of the two Generals had done this on their own initiative. The real question was why they had done it.

She pondered this while her programs worked on analysing the code of the last group of peripherals and Catra needled Sidorov. From what she could tell, the programs she had discovered monitored all traffic, both data and Stargate traffic. But Russia and China already had access to Stargate Command’s records. They had access to the Stargate as well. They could track any Alliance movement already.

But the Alliance, through the U.N. Security Council, controlled the Stargate. And that must rankle Russia and China. And half the world’s nations that had issues with the Etherians, the West or both, she added. Still, what was the point of this software? They already had access to Stargate Command’s systems.

She frowned and ran a few more checks while the scan continued. Yes, the programs monitored the data traffic, but that shouldn’t lead to performance issues. And wouldn’t have necessitated such a complete infiltration of the systems. No, the reason the performance had suffered was that the program effectively ran the entire system, all peripherals, anything connected, through a subsystem of its own. Merely monitoring the data wouldn’t be enough of a reason for that, nor for the risks they had taken.

No. She pressed her lips together. Whoever had done this wanted to manipulate the system. But to what point? It wasn’t as if they

could hide using the Stargate from the Alliance. Not when three-fifths of Stargate Command was staffed by the militaries of allied nations.

Or could they?

Sam ignored Sidorov's yelling in the background - Catra had made him lose his temper entirely - and focused on the subverted systems. If you could manipulate the security system and the database, you would be, in theory, able to manipulate the system so you could sneak strangers through the Stargate by placing trusted people in key positions.

But because of such threats, the Alliance ensured that no matter what, someone trusted kept eyes on the Stargate at all times. And Russia and China already had the opportunity to sneak spies or diplomats on missions by listing them as military personnel; it wasn't as if the Alliance could dispute such claims. So, this was pointless.

Unless, Sam realised with a sinking feeling, some of the trusted staff on Stargate Command had been suborned by Russia or China. Or both.

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Spy Games Part 1

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 6th, 1999

Spies.

Catra wouldn't say that she hated spies. They had their uses. All other things equal, the side with the better information won a war. Sometimes, even if things weren't equal. And spies were usually the only way to get the kind of information your scouts and recon missions couldn't get. But spies also worked by earning and then betraying the trust of their targets. Sometimes, that just meant wearing the enemy uniform to sneak into a base. But sometimes, that meant working for the enemy, rising through the ranks, becoming friends with them - and then stabbing them in the back. Occasionally, that kind of betrayal included turning people against their friends. And hurting people just for the heck of it.

She clenched her teeth and forced the memories of that last talk with Double Trouble away. Then she noticed how everyone was glancing at her. Sidorov was looking a bit pale. Oh - Catra's claws were out. And had torn through the edge of the console she was sitting on. She hadn't noticed. That was embarrassing. But also useful.

She flashed her fangs. "So, we don't just have to deal with a spy, but with a potential saboteur. Or an assassin."

"That's a ridiculous accusation!" Sidorov bellowed. "Even if this were a spy program - it could just be a program to monitor the system for faults."

"Bugs, not faults." Gregorovich corrected him. "Mistakes in programs are called bugs in English. Colloquial English."

"Whatever!" the Russian snarled. "There is no assassination!"

“But there could be!” Sam cut in. “If the iris is closed after the wormhole has stabilised and the clearance codes have been sent, the result would be fatal for anyone stepping through the gate. And if the system is thoroughly compromised, the Stargate could be forced to dial to another location than the desired one, leaving a team stranded - or worse.”

“But that would be obvious since we could still see the symbols as the chevrons lock,” Haig objected.

Sam blinked. “Yes, but that would require someone to check the address visually.”

Catra snorted - Sam didn’t say it, but Catra had a feeling that few of the current people working at the Stargate were that familiar with the symbols.

Hammond frowned. “We will have to adjust our procedures.” Then he shook his head. “But that can wait until we have exposed everything behind this. We need to know who has so completely penetrated our computers - and how.”

Well, the answer to the first question was crystal clear: Sidorov and Li were behind that. Probably on orders from their leaders. The answer to the second question was probably something simple, like giving orders to a Russian or Chinese soldier working on or with the computer.

Guilty.

Catra nodded. But while Melog confirmed it for her - and for the Princess Alliance - their Earth allies would want more proof before they would accuse Russia and China of betraying them. Politics at work. “Well, I’m sure Sam will be able to tell us how this was done.”

“I’m going through the logs. They will have hidden their manipulations, but there are ways to check for traces. Inconsistencies, buffers that were incompletely cleared, small

variables…" Sam was talking without looking up, eyes focused on her screen. "We'll also have to pull the hardware to check."

Catra smiled - and glanced at Li and Sidorov. Next to the snarling Sidorov, Li looked stoic, but she spotted how tense he was. And both of them were glancing around. Checking the guards.

But Hammond had already called SG-3 to the gate and control room; Catra recognised several members of that team from their operation against Seth's compound. And there were British soldiers as well, so the half a dozen Chinese guards next to the Stargate were outnumbered. That should deter any stupidity on the traitors' part.

Should.

If she had been running this spy operation, she would have prepared a backup plan or two. A few distractions ready to be triggered, or something more serious. And she wasn't vain enough to think no one else could have the same idea.

She hopped off the slightly damaged console and walked over to Hammond. "Did you scan for explosives?" she asked in a low voice.

"Every day," he replied.

She nodded. Good. One less worry.

Not too worried.

And that made her worry. If the threat of being exposed didn't worry either of the two traitors, then they must have something planned.

But what? A scapegoat? Maybe they had a subordinate ready to take the blame for this? But that would make them look incompetent. And no one would believe it - not after their reaction to the discovery; both of them had all but outright tried to make

Sam say she had made a mistake. The only way they could have looked more guilty would have been by bragging about it.

Or was that their plan? Were they ready to be the scapegoats for their rulers? Catra was sure Sidorov hadn't thought of this himself. The Russian reminded her of a few Force Captains she had known; no initiative at all, just strict adherence to orders no matter how stupid or costly - unless their own lives were in danger.

"If your claim that someone managed to penetrate the Stargate Command computer systems is true, then that would be a grievous failure of the computer security - a system you developed!" Sidorov glared at Sam.

Li nodded. "Indeed. We were assured that the security of the systems was impenetrable."

They were changing tacks, Catra realised. She glanced at Melog.

Less nervous.

"We said it was the most secure system we had developed," Hammond corrected the general.

"And now you claim it was defeated thoroughly?" Sidorov sneered.

"The best technical security cannot prevent an inside job," Sam retorted.

"Inside job?" The Russian blinked.

"Betrayal by the people with the clearance to operate the system," Sam said.

"Yes!" Gregorovich nodded. "KGB was very good at that."

He sounded almost proud - he was a better actor than Catra had thought. Or there was more to this. Both Li and Sidorov had

tensed up again, she noticed. So, probably not a frame job, as Jack called it, but a turncoat.

"I'm currently analysing the access logs - and comparing them to the various other logs," Sam said. "Any discrepancy should show up soon."

"Other logs?" Sidorov frowned again. Catra wondered briefly if he ever smiled or simply shifted between frowning, scowling, sneering and glaring.

"There are more logs than the main one," Sam said.

"Da. Is like backup for important data so mistake - or sabotage - not wipe all work." Gregorovich nodded. "And what is unknown cannot be sabotaged. Good KGB rule, da?"

Anger.

Well, Catra could tell that herself. Gregorovich was as blunt as ever. But was he trying to cut ties to Russia, or was that a ploy? If it was an act, it was a bit too blatant, too obvious. On the other hand, that might be what they wanted the Alliance to think…

Maybe I've been thinking a bit too much about spies, Catra thought. I'm sounding like Jack in my head.

Sam's computer beeped again, and she looked at the screen. Catra couldn't see the screen from her spot, but she could see Sam's expression change from surprise to shock.

"What did you find?" Sidorov said.

"I'll have to verify that," Sam replied without looking at the Russian.

Catra didn't need to look at the screen to know it wasn't good news. Still, she needed more information, so she slid around the console and peered over Sam's shoulder at the screen. The screen

was full of rows and tables of code and numbers, but that put her face next to Sam's, and Catra whispered: "Who was it?"

"Siler's access codes," Sam replied without moving her lips.

Oh. That was one of the veterans from Stargate Command - Catra had seen him often in the control room back in the mountain. Had they managed to turn him?

"They must have used his codes somehow… Cross-checking the timestamps with the security recordings," Sam went on.

It couldn't be magical compulsion: the Stargate had sorceresses on duty to watch for that.

The computer beeped again. "File not found?" Catra asked.

"What?" Hammond joined them.

"Someone deleted the security recordings of the suspicious access times, sir," Sam reported.

"Suspicious access codes?" Hammond growled more than he asked.

"I am crosschecking their whereabouts during the times in question, sir. But without recordings, we can't prove their innocence."

Smug.

Yeah. So, that was going according to plan.

"There are more ways than security recordings to prove someone's innocence," Haig commented.

"But they take time to gather," Petit retorted. "And people trust recordings more than testimonies."

That, Catra agreed with. She wouldn't trust the word of any Russian or Chinese right now. But they would say the same about

the Alliance.

Was that their plan? Discredit the entire Alliance staff? But what would they gain from that? The United States, France and Britain could always outvote the Russians and Chinese. So, what was the point of this?

She glanced at Melog, but her friend didn't have an answer either.

Then Haig spoke up: "In any case, we'll have to suspend Gate travel until further notice - we cannot risk travelling with compromised security."

Catra froze. She was stuck on Earth? Away from Adora?

She was going to kill those spies!

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 6th, 1999

"...and the Stargate has been closed?" Jack O'Neill asked.

"Until we are certain that the system is free of any unauthorised programs, yes, sir."

The consequences of that… He closed his eyes for a moment. "And here I thought my day was bad enough already." He glanced at Catra, who was staring out the window of his office, unsheathing and sheathing her claws, while Melog was sprawled at her feet like an actual cat. That explained her bad mood, at least. "So, someone tried to frame Siler? And by someone, I mean the Russians and the Chinese."

"We have no proof of their involvement, sir," Carter replied. "But yes, someone used Sergeant Siler's access codes." With a frown, she added: "He has been restricted to the base until we can prove he wasn't present during the times the software was manipulated."

“An idea how long that will take?”

“No, sir. The base entrance logs have been tampered with, so they have been compromised and cannot be used to exculpate him. And the secondary logs we’re piecing together are not as detailed with regard to individuals as they should be.”

“That’s not your fault, Major,” he told her. “As I understood, those secondary logs are the only thing that will allow us to sort out the entire affair because the Russians didn’t know about them.”

“Not by design, sir. Those logs are the result of imperfect system architecture resulting in unplanned accumulation of data.”

Always the perfectionist. He almost snorted, but that would have been inappropriate. “Well, I’m sure you’ll crack this, Major.” And the spooks could handle the rest of the investigation - that was basically police work anyway.

“We should just grab Li and Sidorov and make them talk,” Catra muttered.

Jack softly whistled. Someone was madder than he had thought. “I don’t think the government - governments - would be happy about that. You’re not supposed to do that.” No matter how much you wanted to teach certain individuals a lesson. “At least not to generals from countries with nukes.” The rules were a bit fuzzier about people from countries without nukes. Or had been during Jack’s time in that sort of business.

Catra scoffed. “We’ve got a fleet in orbit. Who cares about nukes that won’t reach their targets?”

Jack shook his head. “There are other weapons of mass destruction. The Russians are sneaky.” And if the Alliance fleet was used against Russia or China - hell, just actually threatening to use it against a country on Earth, instead of implying that by having ships in orbit, would make many Alliance countries uncomfortable as well.

Catra scoffed again. “We can’t let them get away with this.”

“We won’t,” Jack promised. “But we have to be smart about this.” If Hammond heard me right now, he’d probably laugh out loud, he thought. “I knew I shouldn’t have accepted the promotion,” he muttered.

“Sir!” Carter was frowning at him. Couldn’t hide anything from her.

“Just an idle thought, Major. Anyway, is there any good news?”

“Iwan has been very helpful,” Carter replied. “I am sure he suspected something like this as soon as he noticed the system’s performance issues.”

Jack slowly nodded and tried not to clench his teeth. ‘Iwan’ was too damn helpful and too damn friendly in his opinion. And that was based on perfectly rational arguments and wasn’t related to Carter being on a first-name base with the half-limey half-Russian scientist! “Can we trust him?”

She frowned at him. “If he was involved, he could probably have prevented the investigation - at the very least, he could have taken steps to avoid my involvement. Instead, he suggested calling me.”

“It wouldn’t be the first time that the Russians would go to great lengths to insert a spy,” Jack pointed out. “If we think Gregorovich burned his bridges with the Russians and take him in, he’d get access to advanced technology research.” Entrapta would not suspect a thing, and Carter might not be objective, either. And the Russians would gladly sacrifice a dozen generals to get their hands on the latest Alliance gear or plans. Without such technology, their army was obsolete. The same went for the Chinese, of course.

Carter didn’t look convinced. She turned to Catra - and Melog. “Is Iwan a traitor?”

Catra tilted her head to the side, listening to Melog's thoughts or whatever for a moment, Jack knew. "Melog can't actually read thoughts. Gregorovich was nervous, but everyone was nervous," she said. "And he found it funny," she added after a second.

"Funny?" Carter looked surprised.

"Well, he's a Russian; they have a pretty dark sense of humour - if they have one at all," Jack commented.

"Ah." Carter nodded. "I can see that. But he has opposed General Sidorov, and publicly at that."

And Hammond and the others could only do so much. Jack sighed. "I'll see if we can find a spot for him in a safe-ish Alliance program." Somewhere not too close to Carter's crucial research. Maybe set him to analyse Goa'uld entertainment devices. Although the Russians might be able to get valuable information and technology out of that as well. "And we'll have to inform the spooks about this, of course."

Though he suspected that the Alliance spooks had contingency plans for such a situation already. It was the kind of thing they did.

"And what can we do?" Catra asked. "I don't want to sit around and do nothing."

That was a good question. Jack didn't like waiting either.

*****

Royal Palace, Kingdom of Dryl, Etheria, December 6th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and this is my lab - well, one of my labs since there's also the Spacelab near Earth, though that's mine and Sam's, and I also work in Alpha, the research base, but Glimmer owns the moon there, and Alpha, the bot, answers to Adora, so it doesn't really

count I think - I'm not sure, the whole ownership thing is a bit confusing - and my lab in the Fright Zone wasn't destroyed, but I usually only go there if I need to do some work on the factories in the Scorpion Kingdom, and I didn't actually ask Scorpia if she claimed it or not, but this, this here is my first lab! I built my first bots here! And I restored First Ones bots here, too. Unfortunately, almost all of them were destroyed when they were infected by a First Ones computer virus that altered their control matrices and made them attack everyone, and I didn't have the time yet to rebuild most of them, but I still have them in a storage room if you want to see them!"

Adora winced a little at Entrapta's enthusiastic explanation. Some of the details her friend got into would probably not go over well with the Asgard.

"Your bots went out of control following a mishap with technology from the Gate Builders?" Freyr asked a bit sharply.

"Yeah? That's what I said, didn't I?" Entrapta nodded. "It later also infected She-Ra's sword and took over more First Ones tech. For a computer virus, it was really impressive."

"And dangerous," Glimmer added in a flat voice. "Extremely dangerous."

"Have you kept a sample of this technology?" Penegal asked.

"We had to destroy the disc it was installed on to stop the infected bots and other pieces of technology," Entrapta replied with a pout. "I am actually not sure if it was a, technically, a computer virus since it took over tech but it didn't make copies of itself - it was limited to the data carrier it was found on, and given the way it acted - it showed some more advanced decision-making ability - it might have been a sort of bot instead. Technically." She perked up. "I could attempt to reverse-engineer a bot that did that, actually. Since it wouldn't be able to make copies of itself, it wouldn't be self-replicating, which is banned according to Sam,

but if we could make it take over Goa'uld tech, that would be useful, wouldn't it?"

"We don't want a bot-virus that can take over technology," Adora firmly said.

"We don't?"

"No. It's too dangerous," she explained.

"Well, if it were limited to Naquadah-base technology… Although if that included bombs, or if it learned how to combine bombs and Naquadah…" Entrapta trailed off, scrunching her nose as she pondered what Adora suspected were terrible things.

The three Asgard were looking very uncomfortable, she noticed.

"Yes. Such technology shouldn't be developed. As our own war proves, the consequences could be dire - they could threaten the entire galaxy," Thor said.

"Well, the First Ones did it," Entrapta countered. "And the galaxy is still around."

"The Gate Builders view of what they considered safe technology is not something anyone should emulate," Freyr said.

"Yes," Glimmer agreed in a clipped voice. "They also built the Heart of Etheria."

"Oh, right." Entrapta nodded. "I forgot about that for a moment - that did threaten a piece of the Galaxy. And did remove magic from the sector. They were really careless there."

"Did you preserve this 'Heart of Etheria' as well?" Penegal asked.

"No. We destroyed it," Adora told him.

"So, that's a piece of magitech you can't study," Glimmer added with a slightly toothy smile. "And it's not a part of our culture,

either.”

Adora pressed her lips together. Her friend wasn’t too subtle about her opinion of the Asgard’s obvious interest in magitech and equally obvious disinterest in Etherian culture. Except for the Etherian safety culture in research, Adora added to herself. Or lack thereof, in the Asgard’s view. At least Glimmer hadn’t openly called them spies. Not yet.

“Anyway,” she spoke up to change the topic, “Dryl is the leading kingdom for non-magitech technology on Etheria. So…”

A signal from her communicator interrupted her - a priority signal. It must be an emergency! She thumbed the thing. “Adora.”

The voice of a clone answered. “Supreme Commander, We have received a priority transmission from your consort over the spy bot network from Earth. Due to a computer virus, the Stargate has been shut down until further notice.”

She gasped. What? Shut down? Catra! Adora’s love was stuck on Earth! But she was safe - she better be safe - and this affected the entire Alliance. Adora was its Supreme Commander and had her duty. “A computer virus infected the Stargate?” she snapped.

“Apparently, it infected the Earth-based computer system controlling the Stargate,” the Clone replied.

Adora relaxed a little.

Then she noticed how everyone, especially the Asgard, was staring at her.

“The Stargate on Earth was infected by a virus?” Freyr sounded shocked.

“Really?” Entrapta sounded intrigued.

Adora winced. She should have worded her question a bit better, given the circumstances. “No. Well, not the Stargate itself…” she

started to explain.

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 7th, 1999

Samantha Carter had worked under bad conditions before. On board a Ha'tak, hacking computers to sabotage the entire ship, with Jaffa warriors gunning for her team. Or under direct fire. Cleaning up Stargate Command's computers wasn't quite as dangerous. But she couldn't help feeling on edge anyway as she worked - everything she had discovered so far pointed at an inside job, and while the clues they had implicated Russia and China, that didn't mean everyone else was trustworthy. Almost anyone here could be a traitor, and that made her glad that Catra and Melog were around in case someone got desperate enough to escalate from spying to assassination.

Of course, it was also concerning that she still hadn't found out how exactly they had bypassed all the security protecting the computers. Even if they had had official access, there had been measures in place to prevent the suborning of the entire system. And, as she rooted through the databanks and caches, too often tempted to just condemn the entire machine and replace it with a factory-fresh piece, she found more and more clues that didn't quite fit the assumption that this was a HUMINT infiltration job by the successors of the KGB with Chinese support.

The programs planted in the system to sift through the data and manipulate it were easy to understand, following established principles and using bits and pieces from known sources combined with some usually clever original work. Slightly challenging, but nothing she would consider extraordinary. But the routines that dealt with the interface to the Stargate itself? They were too advanced, and they worked too smoothly with the alien technology. She remembered how much work it had taken her to get the whole system to work, and while she didn't want to sound

arrogant, she was one of the most experienced programmers in this area.

Even with the manual and notes she had left, it should have taken a Russian or Chinese programmer longer to subvert the entire system to this degree. Understand, yes - that was the point of the documentation. But to program alternative solutions to hers that wouldn't show up on regular system scans and checks? That was essentially duplicating her work from scratch - and in less time than it had taken her.

She glanced at Iwan, who was running additional checks on a cleared peripheral. Wouldn't he have known about such an individual? She could believe, based on everything she had heard, that the Soviets might have been paranoid enough to keep their research compartmentalised even though that might slow down or cripple some projects, but could Russia have continued such a policy and achieved such results anyway? And would they have worked with China, risking to expose themselves anyway, after taking such extreme measures?

If the alternative was seeing their country, or countries, becoming powerless and irrelevant as the Alliance advanced far beyond them? Probably. The arrival of the Etherians had shaken the entire world to the core and rendered most militaries obsolete.

So, this could be the work of some secret Russian research project. One that had been conveniently easy to adapt to the Stargate project. Too conveniently, actually.

She started another scan, then leaned back. "Hey, Iwan."

"Da?"

"Do you know if yours was the only storage for alien technology?"

She could see him tense for a moment.

"You think this was done using alien technology?" Catra, of course, had heard her - and apparently had deduced Sam's

hypothesis straight away. She shifted on her seat as well, still lounging, but Sam knew her well enough that she didn't have to glance at the colour-changing Melog to tell that Catra was ready to jump into action now. Catra's tail was swishing, and her ears were twitching.

But the really interesting reaction was Iwan's. He stopped typing on his keyboard and glanced at the closed door before answering: "Well, there were rumours. But there are always rumours. Would be stupid to separate research, no synergy, no helping each other, da? But then, Russia has history of doing stupid things with very important - or dangerous - things."

That didn't confirm her hypothesis, but neither did it disprove it.

"Wouldn't your scanner have found another hoard of alien technology?" Catra asked.

"Only if it used Naquadah," Sam replied. "Not every alien technology depends on Naquadah." Etheria or the Horde's didn't.

"But the Goa'uld's tech does," Catra pointed out.

"The technology they adapted," Sam corrected her. "They might have studied other alien technology as well." Some of the Goa'uld, at least.

"And you think that the Russians or the Chinese found such technology and kept it hidden?" Catra frowned.

"Russia found Goa'uld technology and kept it hidden," Iwan said. "Keeping secrets from everyone, even themselves, is Russian way."

"If they had access to unknown alien technology, it would explain how they managed to subvert our security so thoroughly," Sam said.

Catra looked a little doubtful, but she nodded and slowly started to grin. "Great!"

“Great?” Iwan sounded as surprised - and wary - as Sam felt.

Catra bared her fangs. “It means we have to find out if your idea is true. And that means we have to go spying!”

Sam winced, but a part of her relished the idea. Turning the tables on whoever had done this to Sam’s systems was quite appealing.

*****

Earth Orbit, Solar System, December 7th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“...and Sam is sure that the programs used against Stargate Command were based on alien technology because they interface so easily with the Stargate.” Catra shrugged. “According to her, the parts that interface with Earth-based programs are ‘too clunky’ to be made by the same people.”

“Oh.” On the screen in Catra’s cabin on the flagship of the Earth Guard Task Force, Adora frowned in that cute way of hers, with her eyes losing focus for a moment while she pondered this. “So, whoever did this had contact with another species? Or found some relics of theirs and analysed them?”

“Yes.” Catra nodded. “And we’ll find out who did it - and what technology they hid.”

Adora bit her lower lip. “And you want to take the technology.”

Catra shrugged again, smiling. Adora knew her so well. “Of course. It was used against Stargate Command - and against the Alliance as a result - so it’s a legitimate target. No matter what Russia and China try to claim.” Like when Russia tried to claim that only unsecured advanced technology fell under the Security Council’s confiscation order and that they would ‘donate’ the secured technology they had - which was now proven to be a lie. Almost proven.

Adora nodded. “Yes. We can’t let such an attack go, or they’ll try again.”

They would try again anyway, in Catra’s opinion. They had no choice if they wanted to remain a military power. Well, unless they found another source of technology, or an ally, out there in the galaxy on one of the Stargate Command’s exploration missions. Of course, the odds… Catra’s eyes widened. “They might be in contact with another species,” she said.

“What?”

“Sam thought - and Gregorovich hinted at it - that Russia recovered old advanced technology that the Goa’uld had collected back before the rebellion and kept that when they handed over the DHS and other stuff,” Catra explained. “But what if they managed to hide contact with another species? If they can take over the computers, they could also fool other security and smuggle in any gear.”

“Or a visitor acting as an advisor,” Adora said. “We’re monitoring traffic for Naquadah because that reveals Goa’uld even inside a host, but if they are in contact with an alien species that doesn’t use Naquadah, that would be useless.”

Catra sighed as she bared her teeth. “And, like every damn Horde soldier, the guards won’t really look for that kind of deception - not if they think the scanners will spot any attempted invasion or infiltration by snakes.” This was worse than Catra had thought. “We should just bomb them from orbit.”

“Yes,” Adora nodded, then blinked and gasped. “What? NO!”

Catra chuckled. “Relax. I’m joking.”

“Don’t joke about that on a ship of the Third Fleet! Priest could take you seriously!” Adora scolded.

“Priest knows better than that,” Catra objected. “He should know, at least.” You never knew with religious zealots. If he thought

Catra being Adora's consort meant she acted on She-Ra's authority… Priest wouldn't try such a ploy unless he thought it would serve his goals, but that wasn't really reassuring either.

Adora sighed. "You know how he is."

"Yes." Priest had learned far too much from religious leaders on Earth. And the wrong lessons. "But I'm not going to make such jokes where he or his men can hear me."

"Good." Adora sighed. "I should be with you."

Well, Catra wasn't going to disagree with that. "It's all the fault of the Russians. And the Chinese."

"Yes. But we need proof before we can move against them."

"We'll get you proof. Jack's working on that." Catra grinned. "He's mad as hell about this." Jack probably still felt as if he was a member of Stargate Command - and there were a lot of his friends serving there.

But Adora didn't grin in return - she frowned. No, she was concerned.

Catra rolled her eyes. "We're going to be fine." She was no princess, but she could take whatever Earth could throw at her. And chew it up and spit it back out.

"But they're now using their magic…"

"Yes. But we'll manage. Ghosts and everything." Catra hoped so, at least. "Jack's working on that." Jack had said he had a plan to do something about that.

"Jack is?" Adora didn't look reassured. "He doesn't like magic."

"Yes. So, he's very motivated to do something about any magic that could be used against him." Catra could understand the feeling. In the Horde, they had been fighting princesses with

decades of experience with basically bots and rifles. They would have given everything for a princess of their own.

Adora was still frowning. Damn. She was probably feeling guilty about not being on Earth - and worried about Catra and the others here.

"We're going to be ok," Catra told her, smiling softly. "And I'll be back home soon."

Adora slowly nodded. "It's not the same without you. It feels… empty. Luna misses you as well."

A part of Catra was glad to hear that she was so important for her love. But a bigger part felt guilty for not being with Adora.

But she didn't say anything about either. Instead, she nodded.

And hoped she would be back with Adora soon. Being separated again… No, she wasn't going there.

*****

Pentagon, Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, December 8th, 1999

Jack O'Neill had been tempted to hold this meeting in orbit, on board his shuttle, or perhaps a frigate, but given everything that had gone on in the last few days, that would likely have backfired. Less 'be part of the greatest endeavour humanity has ever done before' and more 'watch me show off my private shuttle'. At least with this particular person.

So he straightened and got up, smiling broadly when his visitor arrived. "Good morning, Special Agent Paris."

"General O'Neill." She didn't look like it was a good morning. She looked like she expected a squad of Jaffa warriors to jump out of the filing cabinet and charge her screaming. Of course, with the scandal around Smith breaking - Kinsey had pulled out all the

stops; the press was crying for blood - and her involvement in the investigation, she probably had good reason to be wary despite Wilkinson turning against Smith. Or because of that.

Well, he had worked with worse. “Please have a seat.”

She sat down with a brief nod, all business-like. Well, that matched what they knew about her.

“Coffee?” Jack gestured at the coffee maker in the corner of his (temporary) office. “It’s not Navy coffee, but actually good, I promise.”

Paris turned to glance at the pot. “Did you import an Italian coffee maker for your office?”

He didn’t wince at the implied accusation. Instead, he grinned. “No need for that. The Pentagon contracted for them a year ago for the general staff. Couldn’t stand to be shown up by Alliance headquarters, I guess.”

“Fitting.” Her smile was tight and thin. “I’ll pass, thank you.”

He shrugged and took a sip from his own cup. “So, you’re probably wondering why you’re here.”

“I assume you’re trying to recruit me for your army, General.”

“Not quite.” He grinned again. “Though if you feel like volunteering, we’d take you in in a heartbeat, of course. We need every talented sorceress we can get.”

“I am a thaumaturgist, not a sorceress.”

“Sorceress is the correct term for anyone with the talent to work magic in the form of spells instead of having a magical power,” he told her. Smiling, he added: “That’s what the leader of Mystacore told me, and as the foremost experts in magic from Etheria, I’ll take their word over a feeble attempt by the FBI to placate Bible-thumping politicians.”

She snorted, then looked a little surprised, probably as much at her own reaction as at his comment. “The other agents call us witches.”

Jack had already known that, but telling her he had been spying on them wouldn’t go over well. “That’s not the same, as far as I know.” Castaspella hadn’t gone into detail about the difference, and Jack hadn’t asked at the time. “But you’d have to ask the expert herself.”

“Are you trying to sell me on attending magic school in Etheria?” She snorted, but Jack thought she hid some interest there.

“I wish!” He shook his head, trying not to grin at her surprise. “They’re still sorting out a training program. It seems Earth has unique magic, and they’re not sure that training people like you as if you were Etherians is a good idea.” Unless, of course, you passed the ‘Ancient’ test. Then they wanted you very badly.

“I would have expected such an important question to have been settled by now.”

“Me too.” He sighed. “But that’s bureaucracy for you.” And politics.

She nodded again, still sitting straight and tense, as if she were facing a court-martial - or an internal investigation, in her position. Hell, she probably was facing one by the FBI. “So, if you don’t want to recruit me…”

“Oh, as I said, we’d love to have you!” he cut in.

“...then why did you invite me to this talk? And put enough pressure on my boss to make him order me to attend?”

“I didn’t actually put any pressure on your boss,” Jack corrected her. “I guess he feels like playing nice with us because the government wasn’t too happy about his creative ways to get a secret sorceress training program going.” Not as unhappy as they had been about the CIA program, of course. At least publicly.

“It was all covered by current regulations,” Paris retorted.

“Yeah.” Jack nodded. “All perfectly legal.”

She scowled at him in return. “Like your shuttle.”

“Exactly.” He pondered mentioning Paris’s own private investigation with Wilkinson, but that would feel like blackmail.

“So, will you tell me why you called me?” She was glaring at him now. Time to dial back the snark.

Jack nodded. “Sure. We want you to help us hunt a spy.”

“What?”

“We’ve got a spy problem. And we’d like the FBI to help us hunt down the spy - just like you’re supposed to do, right? It’s an international affair, so the FBI can’t take the investigation over, sorry.”

“You want my help?” She looked suspicious. Not unlike Daniel when Jack praised his books or something.

“You’re the best sorceress the FBI has.” Which wasn’t as impressive as it sounded, but no small feat either.

“You could call in an army of princesses and *sorceresses* from Etheria. Why do you want me?”

They couldn’t actually call in an army from Etheria right now, what with the Stargate down. But that was a military secret. “They don’t have your training as an FBI agent. And we can’t depend on them for everything.” Not forever.

She slowly nodded. “And you fear magic is involved.”

“Well… we don’t know for sure, but it’s a distinct possibility.” He shrugged. “Better safe than sorry, and if we can get a trained investigator at the same time…?”

She snorted again. “I’ll agree to help you under one condition.”

“Yes?”

“You get Wilkinson on board as well.”

Jack blinked. He hadn’t expected that. But he should have, he realised, recalling how Paris and Wilkinson had acted. They were certainly closer friends than they admitted. And her loyalty was a point in her favour. “Sure - if he wants to.”

“He will.” And now she sounded like Carter when she wasn’t going to budge no matter what Jack said.

He chuckled. “I’ll take your word for it. Welcome to the team!”

*****

Spy Games Part 2

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 9th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"They're just here to learn more about magic and magitech. They don't care about our culture at all. We should send them home!"

Adora winced while she watched Glimmer pace and complain - or rant - in her office. "We invited them," she reminded her friend.

Glimmer scoffed. "So we can rescind the invitation. We don't have to let spies stay."

"Unless they're at Princess Prom," Bow pointed out, then grimaced when Glimmer glared at him. "Just saying."

"We aren't at Princess Prom!" Glimmer shook her head and kept pacing.

Adora bit her lower lip for a moment, then asked: "Well, can you really call them spies if all they do is ask questions of their hosts?" It wasn't really fair to call the Asgard spies, in her opinion. They were giving them tours, after all.

"Are we sure that they are just asking questions?" Glimmer asked back.

"Well… we've got them under permanent surveillance," Entrapta spoke up. She was still working on her multitool, though, and her hair tendrils were typing on a keyboard next to her. "Although that's to keep them safe from any attacks, and to prevent Double Trouble from copying them, as you told me. But! It also means we can be sure that they aren't sneaking out of their quarters at night to break into our data banks. Unless, of course, they managed to fool our security."

"Could they have done this?" Adora asked. First, the Stargate Command computer got taken over, and now this?

“Well… It’s possible. In theory. Nothing is impossible, after all.” Entrapta smiled as she nodded. “So, yes, they could have done this. That’s simple logic.”

Adora suppressed a sigh, and even Glimmer looked taken aback for a moment. “Uh, is it likely that they could have done such a thing?”

“Wellll…” Entrpata scrunched her nose. “That’s a different question. We don’t know everything about their technology, especially their computer technology. I’ve taken scans of their sensors on Cimmeria, but I don’t think that was their best work. And Horde Prime used their technology for his systems, but he had a long time to develop it further, so we can’t judge Asgard technology based on Horde technology. Still, there are similarities. Also, since they’re fighting bots, they probably have good computer security, so they should also be good at penetrating computer security - you can’t have one without the other, you know? You wouldn’t be able to test your security measures without having the skill to penetrate it. And as Loki told us, a lot of their technology is heavily automated, especially their ships, so that’s another point for them being good at computers - you can’t have good bots, and automation is just another term for having bots do the works, without good computer technology. Control matrices with the required complexity for bots, even if they aren’t self-learning ones, need good computers. On the other hand, Loki didn’t seem to have better computer technology than we do. Then again, he is kind of banned from their research, so he wouldn’t have access to their best systems. On the other hand, since Horde technology is based on Asgard technology, the similarities would make it a bit easier to hack a computer than if it were a truly alien system - which is why I so want to take a look at the programs Sam found. Imagine the data we could get from an alien system! Anyway! We don’t have enough data to tell what the Asgard could do.”

Adora blinked. That had been a lot of words for basically ‘we don’t know’.

“So, we have to assume the worst,” Glimmer said.

“No!” Adora shook her head. “We can’t assume the worst of others!”

“Unless we’re defining security procedures. At least Hordak said that,” Entrapta added. “You need to prepare for the worst mistake you can think of because someone will do that.”

Ah, yes. ‘Kyle-proofing’ was what Catra called it.

“Whatever. We still have to face facts: We can’t earn the Asgard’s trust by showing them our culture. We’re too different from each other,” Glimmer said.

“Well, I think just making the attempt has helped us. Showed our good will.” Bow smiled.

Adora’s smile was a little forced. She didn’t want to be a downer, but in her impression, the Asgard’s experiences on Etheria so far had hurt their trust in the Alliance as much as they had helped it. At least as much.

“If they dislike our culture as much as dislike theirs, we might have been insulting them for the entire visit so far,” Glimmer pointed out. “At least they have been more polite about that than some of us.”

Adora winced again, and Bow blushed a little. Lance and George had been enthusiastic about the Asgard but also a bit too honest.

“But back to our security: Entrapta, we need you to double-check our systems. Just in case,” Glimmer said. “And we’ll have to get more guards, in case our sensors are compromised. Can’t fool people the same way you can fool a bot.”

“Unless you’re Double Trouble,” Bow said.

Entrapta nodded. “Or unless you use optical illusions backed with sound. That would fool both people and bots, as long as the bots

don’t have other sensors. That’s why I always build my bots with multi-sensory scanners!”

Glimmer ignored both and looked at Adora. “And we need to decide what to do with the Asgard. It’s pointless to show them more of our culture. We need to do something else.”

Adora nodded. The question was: What could they do? She had an idea, or at least the start of one, but the others wouldn’t like it. Still, they had to do something. And they were her friends. They would hate her for suggesting it.

She cleared her throat. “I had an idea about that…”

*****

Adora checked her appearance in the mirror, turning her head left and right to get a different angle. She looked presentable and nodded to herself. For a moment, she expected a dry comment about vanity, or a sappy one about being beautiful from every angle, but Catra was stuck on Earth, and her friends here were…

“I still think this is a bad idea.”

“We all agreed it was the best idea we had.”

“That doesn’t make it a good idea.”

“Well, that depends on how you define a good idea. Is there an objective or relative good? Or a minimum value you have to reach?”

…still not done with the discussion they had had for an hour. Even though, as Bow had pointed out, they had all agreed that Adora’s idea was the best they had. Which wasn’t very flattering since it was the only idea they had, not counting Glimmer’s muttered wish to deport all Asgard. Or make them sit through a medley of Sea Hawk’s worst shanties.

It was kind of weird how the Asgard seemed to annoy Glimmer so much. They hadn't actually done anything to her except for scorning Etherian culture and being curious about magic. Not unlike Catra having made some scathing comments about Bright Moon's traditions, and Entrapta still having some issues with boundaries when she was fascinated by something.

On the other hand, dealing with the Asgard's continuing lack of trust was frustrating. Adora and her friends only wanted to help them! And they would help them, one way or another!

Nodding again, she turned to the others. "Let's go before it's too late to visit them."

"Why would it be too late to visit them? Oh, is that about bedtime? If we want to be sure that they aren't asleep yet, we can call ahead! Although if they didn't set their comm on silent, we'd wake them up that way. Oh. That would kind of explain why people were always awake when I called, wouldn't it?"

This isn't the time to ask Entrapta for an explanation, Adora told herself. Besides, she could guess what happened. And she could imagine Catra's reaction if Entrapta ever called them when they were asleep.

She chuckled at that thought as she walked to the door. "Let's go!"

"But what if they are asleep?" Entrapta asked.

"They aren't. We have them under surveillance," Glimmer replied.

"Isn't that violating their privacy? Even if it is for their own good?" Entrapta cocked her head to the side.

"It's a security measure." Glimmer scowled a little, Adora noticed.

"Oh. It's for our own good, then?"

“It’s to ensure that nothing happens to them or us while they are our guests,” Bow explained.

“OK.”

At least by the time they reached the guest quarters - which weren’t the guest quarters that had been used as cells for prisoners in the past - Entrapta was focusing on her tool again, and Glimmer and Bow were busy keeping her from walking into walls.

If the Asgard saw us right now, they would lose even more trust, Adora thought. But she forced herself to smile and knocked on the door.

Penegal opened the door. “Yes?”

“Hi!” Adora beamed at him. “Can we come in? We have something important to discuss.”

“Something to discuss outside a formal meeting,” Glimmer added.

“Oh. And what would that be?” Penegal looked wary, in Adora’s opinion.

“Magic and magitech,” she replied.

“Please come in!”

Adora didn’t have to glance over her shoulder to know that Glimmer was giving her the ‘told you so’ look, even though everyone knew that the Asgard were fascinated by Etherian magic.

Freyr and Thor were sitting on the couch in the living room of their suite, the one sized for their height, and had overheard them - both were staring at Adora and her friends intently.

“You want to talk about your magic? Off the record?” Freyr asked when everyone had sat down.

“We want to talk about it informally, not off the record,” Glimmer corrected him.

“Ah.”

“Without all the, ah, trappings of a formal diplomatic meeting,” Adora explained. “Just a straight talk.”

“Ah.” Freyr nodded.

“It’s kind of obvious that you’re not really interested in our culture,” Glimmer started. “And that you’re very interested in our magic.”

“Which is part of our culture,” Bow added.

“Yes.” Thor sounded a bit… snobby? Or maybe Adora was imagining it. It was hard to read the Asgard.

“You are very interested in magic, but the Asgard can’t actually use magic,” Glimmer went on. “Loki told us that,” she added.

“He would,” Thor said.

“Even if he hadn’t told us, the fact he didn’t ask to be taught magic would have kind of given that away.” Adora shrugged. “Not completely, but we would have noticed.”

“So, we’re wondering why you’re so interested in magic,” Glimmer continued. “Are you planning to attempt to use magic to fix your genome?”

“It is doubtful that magic could fix it,” Freyr said. “Or you would have suggested it already. Right?”

Adora was sure that she didn’t imagine the challenge in that question. “We haven’t suggested it so far because you seem to have issues with altering your species’s genes,” she told him. “And if magic can fix your genetic degradation, you would be altered.”

“Like reset to an earlier version, if you were a program,” Entrapta not so helpfully added. “Probably at a point magic considered ‘healthy’ - if it works. Which is kinda doubtful since healing magic doesn’t change people’s species. It does fix genetic disorders, though - we found that out when Adora healed so many people in India. But magic won’t fix a Jaffa’s genetically engineered missing immune system, even though that is clearly not healthy. But! Those are just theories. We won’t know for sure unless Adora tries healing you. So, do you want to try that?” She beamed at the Asgard.

Who were now looking decidedly uncomfortable.

“You talk as if magic possesses a will of its own,” Freyr said.

Glimmer frowned. “Well, it does? Magic chose She-Ra, for example. You know that.”

The Asgard looked at each other. “We thought this was a… cultural assumption,” Freyr said.

“You thought we made that up?” Adora blinked.

“It sounded like a religious belief,” Thor replied. “Not a scientific fact.”

“It is proven by science.” Entrapta nodded. “We have the empirical data and records to prove it. Well, mostly - the records are a bit iffy, being so old. But that’s just one example. There are others. Mostly on Mystacore, though. Or in their archives.”

The Asgard looked at each other.

“We would like to visit Mystacore,” Penegal said.

“Ah.” Adora winced. “We can ask them.” Again, she added silently.

“If you ask them to let them do the magic healing experiment on you, I am sure they’ll invite you!” Entrapta tried to help.

Adora winced again. Technically, this was exactly what she had been thinking of - offering the Asgard magical healing and information about magic. But the way it was shaping up wasn't how she had hoped this would go.

*****

Pentagon, Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, December 9th, 1999

"You want me to help you hunt down a suspected alien spy in Russia."

Wilkinson looked wary, Samantha Carter thought. Not very eager to be part of this - though she had expected that, given what they knew about the man. He was a lone wolf, not really a team player. Or, she corrected herself, not a good team player unless he was leading the team.

And this team already had a leader.

"Or China - we're not sure yet." The General grinned. "So, you might get a lot of frequent flyer miles out of this."

Of course, making a roundabout joke about the exact thing he had almost been framed for was exactly what the General would do. Sam suppressed a sigh while Daniel whispered to Sha're, probably explaining what frequent flyer programs were. Catra chuckled, but that was no surprise.

Wilkinson, though, frowned, and Paris rolled her eyes. "I didn't know you had a background in military intelligence, General O'Neill," he said.

"I am a man of many talents." The General shrugged. "Though you're right that I wasn't formally part of military intelligence."

"Your record was heavily redacted."

"Yes." Another grin that showed a bit too many teeth.

Sam wanted to roll her eyes as well. This was posturing, and they had a job to do. "We have no conclusive proof that alien technology was used to infiltrate Stargate Command's systems, but the data we have is quite convincing."

"And Russia and China are the main suspects," Catra cut in. "They have the motive for it and shouldn't have the means."

That earned her a frown from Wilkinson. The man probably loathed pop culture's portrayal of his work. Sam certainly didn't like how most scientists were portrayed in TV shows. Especially most female scientists. Or most female soldiers. That the Etherians seemed to like Earth media despite this common bias… She forced herself to focus on the task at hand and spoke up again: "I've analysed the code of the programs we found, and it contains parts that are too original to be deduced from existing Earth-based tools as well. Combined with the smooth integration of the program with the Stargate technology, the most obvious explanation is that they used alien technology."

Wilkinson kept frowning, but he didn't question her conclusion.

"The question is," the General went on, "did they find some alien relics left on Earth thousands of years ago and kept them secret while they analysed the technology? Or are they in contact with an unknown alien species, and that's where they got the tech from?"

"How would they have kept such contact secret from the rest of Stargate Command if they didn't have the technology that allowed them to infiltrate the system yet?" Wilkinson asked.

"Good question!" The General smiled. "If they got the tech during their first contact, they could have used it after their team returned. That way, they could have kept the next trips a secret. It wouldn't have taken much, anyway, to hide such a contact - they could easily travel to one planet and then dial to another from there, with no one the wiser back home. But they would

need more control over the system to smuggle things through the gate. Or people."

"And that's what you are afraid of: a covert alien invasion."

"Concerned, not afraid," the General corrected him. "Any invasion would have to deal with the guard fleet in orbit before making headway. And our anti-body snatching protocols are pretty good - we don't just rely on Carter and Entrapta's magic scanner."

Sha're tensed at that, Sam saw, and Daniel took her hand and held it.

"That seems a bit careless," Wilkinson said. "They managed to hide their infiltration of Stargate Command from the Alliance, didn't they?"

"Not successfully," Catra said. "And they had a big advantage since they were working from the inside."

"I don't think we should dismiss the possibility that we became complacent, though," Daniel commented. "We might have relied a bit too much on established technology and procedures. Even, or especially, since they were working so well." He smiled apologetically at Sam.

But her friend was right - the system should have been protected against such an attempt. It was embarrassing - especially for her; she had been responsible for most of the computer security until her transfer to the Alliance.

"When did this happen?"

"Three months ago at the earliest," the General said. "That's when the programs were inserted. But if they had contact with aliens, it could have happened at any time since they started sending teams through the gate, but probably not too much before that unless they got really lucky and then rushed things. Which doesn't fit either Russia or China."

"Both governments must be under immense pressure," Daniel pointed out. "With NATO building spaceships, they might have felt compelled to take considerable risks to keep up and so moved without the expected caution."

"Or they were manipulated by aliens," Sha're said. "The desperate are easy victims for such ploys."

"Yes." The general nodded. "In any case, handling Russia and China isn't our problem; that's for the politicians. Our job is to catch a bunch of spies. So, now let's talk about how we're going to do that!"

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 9th, 1999

Catra was, once again, very glad that the new Stargate Command location included integrated hangars for shuttles. Just walking over the tarmac - which was covered in snow - would have been a hassle in what was, apparently, 'not even close to a blizzard' according to the Canadians but looked very much like a snowstorm to her.

"This makes me miss Washington in the winter," Paris commented to Wilkinson behind her.

"We're not going to stay here for long," he replied. "Just examining the crime scene."

That seemed a bit optimistic to Catra. She glanced at Melog.

Honest.

So, Wilkinson believed this? She snorted. "Don't jinx it," she said, looking over her shoulder.

"I don't believe in superstition," he replied.

“Like you didn’t believe in magic?” Catra retorted, flashing her fangs for a moment.

He frowned at her in return, then glanced at Paris.

“We didn’t cover ‘jinxing’ in the course,” the sorceress told him. “But there are theories that common ‘superstition’ such as this might have a base in reality - or shape reality now that magic was returned.”

Wilkinson seemed surprised. And definitely not pleased. “Why am I only hearing this now?”

“It’s just a theory,” Paris replied. “There are dozens like it. We’re still trying to figure out how magic works on Earth. A lot of what we knew once has been distorted during the last thousand years.” She glanced at Catra.

Catra shrugged. That wasn’t her fault, for once. “Yeah, the First Ones messed up a lot of planets when they redirected their magic.”

“Except for Etheria,” Paris said.

“Only because they were stopped before they could use all that magic to blow up Etheria to power a superweapon to take out their enemies.” Catra smiled grimly. “And their superweapon was still active and ready to fire when we took it out.”

“I never heard about those details,” Paris echoed Wilkinson’s earlier complaint.

Catra shrugged again. “It’s classified information.”

“And you’re telling us?” Wilkinson glared at her. Was he mad that he had been told a secret and didn’t have to find it out himself?

“You’ve got the clearance for such stuff now,” Jack cut in, walking down the ramp behind them, followed by Sam, Daniel and Sha’re. “Can’t investigate Stargate Command without it.”

"I don't remember signing anything to that extent," Wilkinson complained. "Or being informed of it."

Jack shrugged. "I've just told you now."

"That's…"

"...perfectly fine in the Alliance," Catra interrupted Wilkinson. For a 'loose cannon', the man cared too much about everyone else following what he thought was proper procedure. At least in her opinion.

Thinks special.

Well, he wasn't alone with that.

Jack clapped his hands together as the special forces they had fetched from Germany on the way here joined them. "Folks! You know your job, so let's get to it! Fan out, we'll meet up again at dinner time!"

And that was her clue. Catra nodded and started walking toward the lift leading down to the main part of the base. The one for people, not the huge one for cargo.

Safe, Melog commented as they approached the guards - French ones - there.

That was good to know. Keeping the team safe was part of her job, after all - you couldn't trust anyone in Stargate Command right now. Not when they might have been compromised. Or manipulated by aliens.

It wasn't a long trip - unlike at Cheyenne Mountain - and Catra's ears caught Isa whispering and Campbell about not liking being so 'hemmed in'. She snorted - the cabin was large enough for scorpion-people, so it was probably just soldiers complaining about everything.

General Hammond was waiting for them when the doors opened. "General O'Neill."

"General Hammond."

Concerned.

Well, Catra could see that. And it was understandable, what with two-fifths of the people on base potential traitors.

"We've brought more help in. Special Agents Paris and Wilkinson, FBI." Jack nodded at them. Special agents, General Hammond."

The three exchanged polite greetings.

"Russia and China have lodged a formal protest against the Alliance investigation," Hammond told them as they walked towards the gate and control rooms.

"So we were told," Jack replied.

"Generals Sidirov and Li also pointed out that the main suspect was Sergeant Siler, a member of the US armed forces, not one of their people."

Catra snorted at that. As if anyone would believe that!

"Clearing him will take a bit more time," Jack said. "But we're working on it."

Well, they were working on investigating and exposing the Russians and Chinese, but it should work out the same. Eventually. But that wasn't really a concern for Catra.

At their destination, Sam split off to check the gate computers, Jack went on to meet with the rest of the Command Council and Catra, followed by Wilkinson and Paris, headed into the gate room.

They had to be sure that the gate was safe before proceeding. And it looked safe - Iris closed, American and British guards present, sorceress on duty.

“A satyr?” she heard Wilkinson mutter behind her.

Right, the man probably hadn’t seen goat-people before.

“It’s a goat-woman,” Paris corrected him. “Not a satyr.”

“Looks like a satyr to me. Hooves and horns.”

The woman saluted as they approached her. “Commander Catra.” She didn’t show any resentment or seemed ill at ease, so she probably wasn’t a Princess Alliance veteran. “Kira,” she introduced herself.

Catra returned the salute, noting that the name matched her tag on her Earth-style uniform - without boots, of course. “These are Special Agent Paris, an Earth sorceress, and Special Agent Wilkinson.”

Kira perked up as she extended her hand for Paris to shake. “An Earth sorceress! I’ve heard a lot about your magic!”

“We’re still figuring it out,” Paris replied with an apologetic smile.

“She’s the best of her class,” Wilkinson commented.

That earned him a frown from Paris, but Kira looked even more interested.

Catra would have to keep an eye on them - it wouldn’t do for their sorceresses to be distracted by a magic discussion right now.

But the gate room looked safe. For now, at least. And Paris and Wilkinson were staring at the Stargate. Right, they hadn’t seen it before. Not in person, Catra reminded herself. When you travelled through the gate almost daily, it quickly stopped being extraordinary.

“It’s fascinating, right? To think this device, and without any magic, allows us to travel from one end of the galaxy to another… It’s marvellous!” Kira, apparently, hadn’t used the Stargate often enough.

“It’s hard to believe,” Wilkinson replied.

“Doubting Thomas,” Paris muttered under her breath.

“Two years ago, this was science fiction,” he shot back.

“No, two years ago, it was real, just a secret.”

That made Wilkinson pause for a moment. Then he nodded. “You’re right.”

“Of course I am.”

Catra narrowed her eyes slightly at the exchange. So, Wilkinson was one of those people. Well, best to put him to work, then.

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Yeah, Sidorov and Li are guilty as hell, Jack O’Neill thought as he tuned out the loud protestations from the Russian general and the more polite but still fake ‘concerns’ of his Chinese colleague. Or co-traitor, even though Daniel would probably tell him that it wasn’t a real word.

And Carter would probably mention that it was not treason according to the legal definition. But Jack didn’t care - if you stabbed your fellow soldiers in the back, you were a traitor. The Russians and Chinese had joined Stargate Command. Their soldiers had been treated as Stargate Command members like everyone else - Jack had trained them. Hell, Jack and his team had risked their lives to save them when things had gone wrong.

And in return, those bastards had sneaked some alien spyware into the base’s computers and done who-knew-whatever-else.

Ah, Li had finished ‘helpfully’ ‘reminding’ them once more that all the evidence pointed at Sergeant Siler being the culprit, and Sidorov seemed to have run out of steam for now. Time to end this charade. “Your concerns have been noted,” Jack told them in his best diplomatic voice - and with his toothiest grin. “And they will be given the attention they deserve while we, in accordance with the decision of the Stargate Command Council, keep investigating the matter.”

“Your sham of an investigation! It’s clear that you are trying to cover for your people!” Sidirov hadn’t run out of steam.

“I must agree - this seems like a highly biased affair.” Li shook his head. “And the timing, so close to the scandal involving another of your generals, seems a bit too convenient.”

The bastard didn’t just go there, did he? Jack swallowed his first response and shrugged as casually as he could manage. “Noted. Do you have anything new to add?” He waited a moment. “Didn’t think so.” Turning to Hammond and the rest of the Command Council, he added: “So, we’re going to continue our investigation.” Carter and the others should already be at work.

He left the room, nodding to Campbell and Isa to follow him - Jack wouldn’t put it past the Russians or Chinese to try something drastic, whether or not they were under the influence of unknown aliens, and while he knew he was good, having help at hand never hurt. Especially if part of the help was the closest you could get to a walking tank without getting a bot.

His next stop was the gate room. Carter was busy at the main console, as expected - they had to clear the gate for operation as fast as possible. And the soldiers assigned to her were standing close by. But he couldn’t see the others.

He walked over. “How’s it going, Carter?”

“Slowly, sir,” she replied. “We have to be very careful not to miss anything.”

Jack clearly heard the 'again' despite Carter not saying it. She was still blaming herself for this, was she? "I trust you to handle it." That sounded a little corny, didn't it? He cleared his throat. "So, where are the others?"

"Catra took them to check the labs and talk to Iwan, sir."

"Ah. I'll head down there myself then." Wilkinson meeting Iwan the Too-Friendly? Jack had to see that!

"Sir."

Getting to the labs didn't take him long - but it took him through two manned checkpoints, one of them with both Chinese and French soldiers, and you'd have to be blind and deaf to miss the tension. Jack would have preferred to remove all Russian and Chinese troops from key parts of Stargate Command, but the Alliance Command Council had disagreed. Well, if things ended with people shooting each other, he knew who would be to blame.

He knocked and entered the lab without waiting for an answer.

"...and this is another weird alien device. Lots of those in the galaxy, da? And all different weird. Oh, hello, General O'Neill." Gregorovich smiled at Jack, apparently not at all unhappy about the interruption.

"I see," Wilkinson said, then turned to glance at Jack.

"It's not magical," Paris added before nodding at him as well. "General."

"We're checking out alien relics," Catra told him. "No luck so far, though."

"I don't recognise any of them," Sha're added. Daniel just muttered something without looking up from staring at a stone table on a side table.

"Would be embarrassing for me if I missed suspicious alien programming technology under own nose." Iwan smiled in that annoying manner of his.

Embarrassing and incriminating. Jack nodded and took a step closer to check what they were doing. "Are those new relics?"

"Recovered by various teams during last few months," Iwan confirmed. "But all under lock and key."

Jack managed not to snort. If Iwan was compromised, then that wouldn't mean a thing since he was working with the relics. He glanced at Wilkinson. The spook had realised that as well, judging by how he stared at the Russian.

Or he didn't like the Columbo act Iwan had going on. Either way, it seemed things were OK here.

Which meant he could go and conduct his own interview. Once he found his target, of course.

Which took a bit longer than expected, even taking the disrupted schedule into account. It seemed that the dear Lieutenant Lenkova was not in her quarters or the training area. According to the log, she was outside.

Which meant Jack also had to go outside. In the middle of December. In damn Newfoundland. And no matter what Daniel and Carter liked to say about the local climate being warmer than in continental Canada and Catra's comments about the place having nothing on Greenland or the Kingdom of Snows, it was still below freezing. "I'm getting too old for this," he muttered when he slipped a parka on in his shuttle.

"Sir?" Campbell asked.

"Nothing." Jack shook his head. He was tempted to tell Campbell and Isa that they didn't have to come with him, but that would be stupid. You couldn't trust anyone from Russia right now. Besides,

they had gone through arctic training, so this should be easy for them.

And it wasn't as if they had to trek through the wilderness to find the Lieutenant. Due to having been a Go'auld host, she still had traces of Naquadah in her body - enough for Carter and Entrapta's magic scanner to find her. The magic scanner in Jack's shuttle, of course - he didn't quite trust the base's sensors right now, even though Carter had reported that the sensor net matched the scanner's results. Jack knew the Russians were too experienced at this sort of thing to give the game away by having the sensors permanently ignore their people.

Still, Lenkova was at the very edge of the base area, in the most remote of the training areas, and the ploughs were focusing on more important areas, so Jack and his escort had to hike quite a bit through deep snow and in the middle of heavy snowfall.

"Reminds me of the expedition to the north," Isa commented behind him.

"Oh?" Campbell sounded interested. Anything to distract yourself from the cold, Jack guessed.

"Yeah. We went there to look for some First Ones tech."

"In the Kingdom of Snows?"

"No, not quite that far north. But it was cold enough to feel it even through our uniforms. That was back in the Horde."

"Ah. Was it as cold as here?"

"Colder, I think. But we forgot about that when the Alliance - the Princess Alliance - attacked. Blew up the entire forward base we had built. Not our finest hour."

Campbell made an agreeing sound.

“Didn’t even have special training - we just got basic instructions for arctic operations and then we were sent up north. Some had to watch the lessons in the transports.”

“Really?”

“Yeah. The Horde was often like that - some stuff you trained every day even though you could do it in your sleep, and some did, and other stuff was rushed like hell.” Isa snorted.

“No wonder you lost the war.”

“Heh! We were still more organised than the Alliance!”

“Really? That’s hard to believe. The Etherian units we’ve met were well-trained.”

“That’s because the entire Horde leadership switched sides.”

Not quite how Jack had heard it. Technically true, but if the grunts were talking about the Horde War like this, he had to nip that in the bud. “The Horde was organised differently,” he said without looking over his shoulder, “because they were preparing to fight a different war than the one the Princess Alliance fought.”

“Yes, sir!” Campbell replied with the familiar reflex of a grunt caught by their commander.

“But we were fighting the same war!” Isa protested.

Jack grinned even though they couldn’t see it. “And that was the problem for the Horde.”

“Oh.”

For a moment, the two soldiers behind him fell silent, and then they turned a corner and reached the training area. Where, as Jack could see, Lenkova *wasn’t* training unless it was some Russian kind of ‘meditation while standing’ thing he wasn’t familiar with. But he would place good odds on her just staring at the sea.

“Lieutenant Lenkova.”

She jerked, whirling around, then froze as she spotted him. “General O’Neill?”

“In the flesh.” He couldn’t see her face very well at this distance, and with her all wrapped in winter clothes, but he thought she sounded surprised - and guilty. “I wanted to talk to you.”

Even in the thick winter uniform, he could tell that she was tensing up. Of course, soldiers usually did that when they were faced with a general taking an interest in them, doubly so for female soldiers, but… Jack had a feeling that there was more to this.

He signalled to Isa and Campbell to hang back a little and walked up to Lenkova. “Taking in the sights? The snow is really great this time of the year.” If he squinted, he could see the shore through the falling snow. Barely.

She hesitated for a moment, then replied: “It’s better than Siberia in the winter.”

“So I’ve heard.” Despite any rumours to the contrary, he had never operated in Siberia, much less during the winter.

Lekova looked at him with narrowed eyes but didn’t say anything.

“So, how’s life at the new base?” Jack asked. “Feeling nostalgic yet?” He didn’t wait for her to reply and went on: “It wasn’t really a consideration when they picked the new location for the Stargate, but Cheyenne Mountain had at least a decent town nearby. One used to the big base. It’ll take some time until you have a decent selection of bars here. Well, not without a shuttle ride or at least a personal plough.”

She didn’t snort at his joke. “Yes.”

“It won’t take too long, tough - people know what a money-maker a bar near a base is. Especially in the middle of nowhere.”

"Yes."

Another short, terse reply. With the snow, and the heavy clothing and hood, he couldn't see too much of Lenkova's face, but what he saw told him enough. She was too tense. "So, how have missions been?"

She hesitated a fraction of a second, then bit out: "Good."

"Really?" He raised his eyebrows, though she probably couldn't see that. "According to the reports I read, it was just boring routine stuff. Trips to known worlds."

"Boring is good sometimes."

He nodded, acknowledging the point. Lenkova would know that very well after her ordeal. On the other hand, she hadn't struck him as wanting to withdraw to safe duties, back before he had transferred to the Alliance. "It isn't boring any more, though, is it?"

She stayed silent for another second. "No, General."

"Quite a mess at the base."

"Yes, General."

"The entire security system compromised… Anyone could have been using the Stargate without Earth knowing about it." He shook his head. "If the snakes know about this…"

Even in the breeze, he heard her draw in a sharp breath. For a moment, he felt guilty for pushing her buttons like this. But he was sure that she knew something about the whole affair, something crucial given her position - and this threatened Earth and the entire Alliance. And she was a Russian spook.

Belatedly, she replied: "The snakes couldn't pass through the scanners. Not even I can pass through them without them detecting the… remains inside my body."

He shrugged again. “The snakes are just one species out there. There are lots more, and many of them are quite nasty. And sneaky.”

She flinched at that. “You would know that better than me, General,” she said in a clipped tone.

Ah! Had she actually met other aliens? And hid it from the official records? Should he push her for more? She still sounded as if she felt guilty to him - and with her background, she should be able to hide that. Unless that was what she wanted him to think so she could feed him misinformation.

But to what point? He snorted softly. Time to push on. “Have you met them?”

She froze for a moment. “Who?” she asked.

“The aliens whose programs were used to hack our computers.”

“Aliens hacked the Stargate computers?” She tried to appear confused or surprised but didn’t pull off either.

“Yep.” Jack nodded. “And you already knew that.”

She straightened a little, lifting her chin. It was as good as a confession.

He kept looking at her without saying a word. Were those tears in her eyes? If they were, was it just the cold?

After half a minute, she sighed, and her shoulders slumped as she looked away. “I suspected about the hacking,” she said in a low voice that he almost missed in the breeze. “We were told not to worry about being discovered.”

He nodded even though she wasn’t looking at him.

“I wasn’t there when we first met them, but I was told afterwards. When it was my team’s turn to meet them.”

“Them?”

“They call themselves the Eurondans.”

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Spy Games Part 3

Mystacor, Etheria, December 10th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Adora's idea had been a bad idea. Or had had bad timing, at the least. They just found out that the Russians and Chinese were in contact with unknown aliens - or alien humans; Jack had said that according to Lenkova, they looked and acted human - and Adora and her friends were still going to Mystacore with Asgard.

But Adora knew that even if they had rescheduled the visit - which would have required them to explain to the Asgard why, though that wouldn't have been too bad since they already knew that the computers of Earth's Stargate had been hacked - it wouldn't change that Adora was stuck on Etheria and couldn't travel to Earth. Couldn't do anything about the problem there. Couldn't be with Catra…

"And we've arrived!" Bow announced from the front of their shuttle.

"We have? I don't see anything," Penegal said, peering through the cockpit's windows. "Just an empty cliffside."

"Mystacore is magically hidden. If we want to enter it, we have to do it here," Glimmer said and opened the ramp in the back.

"Ah." Freyr nodded.

Adora had half-expected them to challenge this - ask why they couldn't land directly in the city. Like most humans would have. But the Asgard just accepted it. Or, she couldn't help thinking, they were too polite to voice such questions.

Once everyone was outside, Bow used his tablet to lock up the shuttle, then had it enter stealth mode.

"Mystacore doesn't use the same method to hide, does it?" Penegal asked.

“No. Mystacore is using magical means,” Glimmer told him. “The shuttles use magitech.”

“Technically, all magitech is a sort of ‘magical means’,” Bow added. “But traditionally, if it doesn’t use any physical tool - like spellcasting - or only glyphs, runes and similar tools, it’s called magic. Anything more complicated is called magitech.”

Glimmer rolled her eyes, probably annoyed at the interruption, but the Asgard nodded. “So, it’s merely a case of traditional yet arbitrary definitions for the same thing?”

“Well, you could say that, yes,” Bow said. “But you’d have to ask a sorceress about it - I’m a tech-master.”

“Who also can build and use magitech,” Thor pointed out.

“Anyone can build magitech if they have access to the right magical resources and know what they are doing,” Bow replied with a smile.

Glimmer snorted, and Adora agreed with her friend’s sentiment - Bow was too modest; it took a lot of talent and effort to learn how to build magitech, even more to develop it.

“And how would one get access to such resources?” Freyr asked.

“That would be a question best asked to Castaspella,” Glimmer replied before Bow could say anything. “And we should hurry - the flying mountain has arrived.”

Adora blinked - she had missed that. The sky and the air in front of them, and below the ledge, looked as empty as always, with just a few clouds obscuring part of the view of the ground. Then again, she wasn’t a trained sorceress, unlike Glimmer. “Let’s go, then,” she said.

“Yes. Just follow me.” Glimmer stepped to the edge, then jumped off.

The Asgard didn't react to that either - they walked up to the edge themselves just in time to see Glimmer rise, standing on a floating mini-island.

"It's perfectly safe," Bow told them, then stepped on it himself.

"I would say that I assume you wouldn't use it if it weren't safe," Freyr said rather dryly, "but your culture's safety standards have been demonstrated not to match Asgard's."

But despite his words, all three Asgard followed Bow and Glimmer on the island.

Adora smiled at that as she jumped on it as well. Maybe this wasn't going to be a waste of time.

The floating island - it looked far more like an island than a mountain, in her opinion - didn't take long to take them to Mystacor.

Still, it was long enough for Penegal to cock his head at Glimmer and ask: "How are you controlling it?"

"Magic," she replied.

"Yes, I assume that is the case, but are you controlling it with mental commands? Or are you using magic on it to steer it?"

"Both." Glimmer's smile looked a little toothy. But before anyone could answer, the island trembled a little, and then Mystacor appeared before them - they had passed through the barrier hiding the kingdom.

And that sight seemed to shut up the Asgard. At least until they had made landfall where Castaspella and the other leaders of the kingdom were waiting for them.

"Welcome to Mystacor," Castaspella greeted them, slightly bowing her head. "Be welcome and at peace while you are here."

“Thank you,” Freyr said.

Adora blinked. That was… “She didn’t greet us like that when we visited,” she whispered to Glimmer while the Asgard mirrored Castaspella’s bow.

“You were there to relax, not as part of a state visit,” Glimmer whispered back.

“Ah.” That made sense. It still felt weird, especially since Castaspella had met the Agsard before. But no one else seemed to feel like that. Adora blamed her Horde upbringing. If Catra were here, she would at least joke about it.

Castaspella introduced the other sorceresses with her, then led the Asgard on a tour through Mystacor - and, since they were with their visitors, that meant Adora and her friends received the tour as well.

“And here’s the Library of the Elements - a relic from an early attempt to categorise magic powers. The theory behind it was disproven after royal lines developed powers that could not be linked to one of the elements, but the library was kept out of tradition.” Castaspella gestured at an old-looking building connected by a path lined with pillars to the main entrance.

“And even expanded,” Glimmer added.

Bow smiled. “If you don’t find anything in the central library, this is your next stop.”

“I don’t understand… you do not have centralised access to your databanks?” Penegal asked.

“No,” Castaspella said. “It’s a matter of security. If anyone would gain access to such a centralised databank, they would have access to all our knowledge. As it is, an intruder would have to physically remove a memory crystal to steal the knowledge contained in it, which would take time and a lot more effort than copying a databank.”

“But… that means your research will be slowed down as well. If you have to physically search through your data…” Pegenal sounded as if he couldn’t believe anyone would have such a system.

“Yes. But while that may seem like a drawback, and often is, sometimes, slowing down a research project can be beneficial.”

“Not every research project should have been started,” one of the older sorceresses stated. “And none should be rushed. Often, a pause can grant someone insight that would have been missed if they had been able to work without rest.”

“Whether that’s the researcher - or those who take care of the library, and of Mystacor as a whole,” a man with few strands of white hair left on his head added.

Adora winced. They meant Shadow Weaver. Or Light Spinner, as she had been known here before her… last experiment. She wondered what the sorceresses here thought of her. But this wasn’t the time to ask such questions - they were here for the Asgard, she told herself with guilty relief.

“It sounds inefficient.”

“It’s also traditional,” Glimmer added with a smile too wide to be honest.

Judging by the way Freyr frowned briefly, the Asgard hadn’t missed that.

And neither had Castaspella, who narrowed her eyes at Glimmer before tilting her head and smiling at their guests. “You also have to understand that research here is a personal affair. Our people decide which idea to research without answering to anyone.”

“Magic shouldn’t be treated as a resource,” the older sorceress, whose name Adora still couldn’t remember, added. “Nor should magic be treated as if it were a machine.”

“And if one were to do that, what would be the consequences?” Freyr asked.

“If you do not respect magic, if you reach too far, or be too greedy or too ambitious, and you might suffer a fate worse than death,” the man said. “Magic… is like a dangerous but beautiful, immensely powerful creature.”

That sounded… well, like Sea Hawk talked about the sea. Or Mermista, when he had drunk a bit too much. At least, Scorpia claimed that.

And Adora didn’t miss the soft snort from Glimmer at hearing this.

But the Asgard nodded. “I see,” Penegal said. “So, it’s more akin to taming a beast than building a tool - or growing a plant?”

“A not entirely incorrect comparison,” Castaspella agreed.

“Is that the case for all magic, or is this a particular aspect of Etheria’s magic?” Freyr asked.

“As far as we know - although our knowledge of other planets’ magic is still very limited - it’s the same for everyone,” Castaspella told him. “At least, Earth’s magical traditions, or the myths based on them, often contain similar warnings of hubris and its consequences.”

Once more, the Asgard exchanged a glance. “And yet, you use magitech,” Penegal pointed out.

“Magitech is not magic as we do here,” Castaspella said.

“Magitech’s magic is… very limited. Constrained,” the man said.

“Dead,” the older woman added.

“Not dead, I wouldn’t say that. But… so limited and bound, it cannot adapt and grow anymore. Cannot live,” he retorted.

“If you cannot live, you die,” the woman said with a smirk.

“Eventually. I would say that magitech keeps the magic in the moment between life and death. Symbolically, at least.”

“Oh, no - they won’t stop now,” Glimmer muttered.

“Symbolically? We’ve heard that Earth’s magic is centred on symbols,” Penegal said. “And that it affects magic.”

“Oh, yes!”

“Not at all!”

The others glared at each other.

“So, this is in dispute?” Thor asked.

“Amongst some,” Castaspella said. “But some of us do not believe that either excludes the other.”

“And there we go,” Glimmer whispered. She glanced to Adora, then her eyes widened. “Oh, no!”

Adora turned to the side and saw Bow frowning deeply. Her friend took a step forward. “As a user and creator of magitech, I have to disagree with the claim that magitech abuses magic. That is a very narrow and biased view, based on concepts that are still mere hypotheses, not facts as some claim.”

“They might as well be facts!”

“That’s not how it works!”

Adora’s smile felt frozen on her face as everyone but Glimmer and herself started to debate. Or dispute - it was hard to tell, given how passionate most were. Even the Asgard.

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 10th, 1999

"So, according to Lieutenant Lenkova, she has met the Eurondans twice so far under cover of doing routine exploration missions, both times escorting diplomats from Russia and China?" Samantha Carter repeated the General's statement out of ingrained habit - and tried not to feel grimly satisfied, or even vindicated, about the fact that Lenkova had been revealed to have betrayed Stargate Command. Or Earth, depending on your definition.

"Yep." The General nodded.

"Diplomats?" Daniel frowned. "They cannot have been high-ranking diplomats; the Russians and the Chinese might have fooled the electronic system and tampered with the records to make them appear as common soldiers or scientists, but I think we would have recognised anyone with influence in either government on sight."

"I think you might overestimate the intel we have on Russia and China, Daniel," the General told him with a slightly rueful grin. "We kind of cut back on the spying we did in the Cold War when Russia collapsed, and with the chaotic mess Russia was left in after the soviet union collapsed, it's a bit hard to keep track of who's actually in power."

"But… their president…" Daniel frowned.

"...will be replaced at the end of the year, in three weeks, by his elected successor - at least that's the official party line," the General interrupted him. "And from what we know, he's been a figurehead ever since the Etherians arrived, maybe even longer. We don't know yet how much actual power his successor has or will have." He shrugged. "Judging from his background, he could have been the power behind the throne for a while or just a puppet for others."

"Gotta love spies," Catra muttered.

“So much for the CIA,” Wilkinson commented. “Can’t even find out who rules Russia.” The FBI agent looked a bit lost but trying to hide it, in Sam’s impression.

Paris, on the other hand, didn’t even try to hide that she thought this was above her head.

“I’m not sure the Russians know who rules them at the moment.” The General snorted. “Anyway, what is clear is that whoever is running things has control over the faction of their military and spy services that run the Russian side here at Stargate Command. Enough to insert trusted agents into their teams here to do some diplomacy for them under the table. And if what Lenkova said about a resource trade being set up is true, they have the backing of at least some of the rich guys currently controlling the Russian economy.”

“What about the Chinese?” Daniel asked.

“Their current leader seems to be entrenched, but that could be a facade so that the Chinese people won’t worry about instability - or question their leaders. They are good at concealing power struggles from us either way,” the General replied. “Last I heard, the CIA analysts are hit and miss with them.”

“For someone who doesn’t like politics, you know quite a lot about it,” Daniel commented with a grin.

The General scowled at him for the little dig.

“You can’t run a war without politics,” Catra said. “So, basically, the Russians want to trade resources for technology? Do we know what kind of technology we’re talking about?”

“Advanced military and medical technology,” the General told her. “But Lenkova claimed not to know how advanced.”

Either the Russian ‘diplomats’ were playing it close to their chest, or Lenkova was lying. Sam pressed her lips together. She couldn’t let her… emotions about the Russian officer influence her thoughts

about the matter at hand. Lenkova had come clean about the Russian - and Chinese - plans; lying about this wouldn't really serve a purpose.

"Advanced enough to take over our - I mean, Stargate Command's - computers," Daniel said.

Sam frowned a little. That had been her responsibility, and she had let them down.

"Yeah."

"But not too advanced," Sha're pointed out. "If they had technology equal to ours, or even the Goa'uld, they wouldn't need anything that Russia or China could provide that they couldn't get themselves. If it were a Goa'uld, they might need Naquadah, but we know that Earth has no deposits."

"The Russians and Chinese might be trying to swindle them. Wouldn't put it past either," the General said.

"That would be extremely short-sighted," Sha're said. "Like an inexperienced Goauld. Although they might count on any retaliation for such a deception dragging the Alliance into the conflict."

"Wouldn't put that past either country either."

"It's also possible that their technology requires resources that are scarce on their planet but not on Earth," Sam said. "Although I can't think of anything that wouldn't be found on other planets either."

"Well, whatever the answer turns out to be, we're going to find out," the General said. "We can't let the Russians and Chinese jeopardise Earth's safety by making shady secret deals with unknown aliens."

"You said that according to Lenkova, the Eurondans were humans." Wilkinson frowned.

The General grinned. “They looked human. That doesn’t mean anything.”

“And, as the Etherians and others prove, merely sharing human genes and origins does not mean we are culturally close enough not to count as aliens,” Daniel added. “We cannot reduce this to a biological question, or we might be working from faulty assumptions that lead to potentially catastrophically wrong conclusions.”

That was correct, but not the General’s point. Sam didn’t say that, though. Instead, she brought up a few files on her computer. “I’ve prepared an overview of the planets where Lenkova met with the Eurondans, sir. We might find more clues at those locations.”

“Once we can use the Stargate again,” the General said. “Until then, this will have to be a local investigation.”

Wilkinson straightened at that, Sam noted.

The General bared his teeth. “It’s time to show our ‘trusted partners’ from Russia and China that they’re not the only ones able to play spy games.”

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Clear.

Catra smiled at Melog’s notice and quickly slid around the corner, then dashed forward to the closest door on the right side of the hallway. It was locked, but the override Sam had put together took care of that with the push of a button, and a second later, she was inside the quarters of the Russian’s latest ‘scientist’, Piotr Novikov - an assumed name, of course.

He was asleep, as expected at this time of the night, snoring slightly. She studied him for a few seconds, watching his chest rise and fall and listening to his breathing. If he was faking it, he would be a great actor. Of course, he was probably a spook, or a former spook… Whatever, she could take him.

She looked around. The room was very neat, very organised - almost sterile. The only personal item she could see was a family picture on the side table. She pulled out her camera and took a few images for analysis, then started going through the man's belongings. According to Jack, it was unlikely that a spook would have incriminating data on them - unless they had reached an agreement to be ratified by whoever was in charge in Russia. Or it was data stolen from the aliens. But that would likely have been moved to Russia already - the last suspicious mission had been a few days before this whole mess had started and Stargate Command had been locked down.

And she found nothing. No scraps hidden in the man's gear. No electronic data, according to Sam's scanner. No…

She narrowed her eyes at a suspiciously scratched corner in the locker. Sure, that could have been from boots thrown into the locker without cleaning them beforehand; she had seen that happen back in her cadet days. But she had also learned how to hide stuff in your locker.

It was easy to slip the tip of a claw under the panel's corner there and work it loose. And behind it was a small cylinder. She didn't recognise it, but it looked quite advanced. And it hadn't shown up on the scanner.

As the humans said: Paydirt!

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Five minutes later, she was back in the lab Sam had appropriated, watching her friend study the device.

"It's a sort of data storage. I'm working on how to access it."

"Good." Jack nodded. "He grinned. "Either the Russians aren't as efficient as they used to be, or our spy here kept a copy of the alien data for himself, or for someone else pulling his strings. Anyway, if you can copy the data before our Russian spook wakes up, we can slip it back in, and he'll have no idea we found it."

“I’ll try my best, sir. But I can’t promise success. This is an alien device with unknown protocols. Though we have samples of their programs, so that should provide us with an advantage.”

“Oh, a data storage device!” Entrapta piped up from the screen in the corner. “Neat!” A moment later, she added: “I’ll help!” And another moment later: “Yes, that will help us!”

Even with the signal routed through the closest Stargate to Earth in reach of the spy bot network - and only as long that one was open to Etheria - the signal lag to Etheria was still a few seconds long. But that shouldn’t be an issue when it came to decrypting. Unlike remote construction or lab work. Or so Entrapta had explained.

Entrapta beamed. “Let’s hope this will be easier than the alien cube!”

Right. The thing they had found on their trip to Earth. Which they hadn’t managed to decrypt yet. Of course, as far as Catra heard, it wasn’t a priority for either Sam or Entrapta, but still - not the most encouraging remark. Then again, Entrapta didn’t mean it like that.

“And what do we do if you can’t encrypt it until the suspect wakes up?” Paris asked. “Put it back?”

“We don’t want to tip them off that we’re onto them,” Jack said. “We can get the thing tomorrow night again.”

Sam tensed at that, Catra saw. She would be working all night to decrypt the device. Well, that was her decision. And the sooner they got more intel about those Eurondans, the better.

She pushed off the table she had been leaning against. “So, let’s hit our next target.” She looked at Wilkinson.

“We could make a copy, I think,” Entrapta chimed in late, interrupting Wilkinson before he could say anything. “A duplicate of the device that looks exactly like it.”

“Let’s focus on cracking the device,” Jack said before looking at Wilkinson.

“Wang Zhen,” Wilkinson said with a slight frown. “Which is like a Chinese John Smith. According to the official documentation, he’s got a doctorate in anthropology, but his publishing history is rather suspect and not available online.”

“Probably majored in propaganda at their spy academy,” Jack commented.

“Ok!” Entrapta cut in.

“I don’t think they call it…” Daniel trailed off and pouted at the grinning man.

Wilkinson cleared his throat. “He’s sharing his room with Captain Li Wei, a legitimate veteran soldier of the People’s Liberation Army, so infiltrating his quarters will be more difficult.”

Catra snorted. More difficult didn’t mean actually difficult. She glanced at Melog. In a pinch, their illusions could probably let her search the room while both were awake.

Ready.

She smiled. “We’ll be right back.”

Jack nodded. “Don’t stay out too late.”

She snorted at that as she vanished under Melog’s illusion. As if!

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 11th, 1999

“We’ve done it, sir. Copied the data on the device in a readable form.”

Carter had worked through the night. Just as Jack O'Neill had known she would. But as he had also known, she had managed to crack the alien data thing they had taken from the Russians. He still felt guilty for not stopping her and making her get some sleep, but that was the price an officer had to pay for doing what was necessary. Like he had done when he had talked to Lenkova, playing on her obvious guilt to make her crack.

Forcing the guilt away, he downed the last of his latest cup of coffee and got up from the seat where he had not quite been napping for half the night. "Yes?"

"We've done it!" Entrapta chimed in, late due to communication lag.

"Good." Catra stretched, yawning and looking rested as if she had slept in a bed and not curled up with Melog on a blanket on the ground. She probably felt the same either way, Jack suspected with a bit of envy; the woman was more cat than you'd suspect upon first meeting her. "Can I take it back then?" Cocking her head, she added: "Novikov is still asleep. Won't take long. Unless you want to tamper with the data on it beforehand."

Jack shook his head. "Take it back. We've got him under surveillance now and can replace it later if we want to." When they were more rested. Trying to be clever and do stunts like this wasn't a good idea when you were operating on a few hours of sleep and a lot of coffee. Unless you absolutely had to, which wasn't the case here.

She nodded, grabbed the thing and vanished from view. Melog was showing off his illusion power again.

Jack waited, cocking his head and trying to hear the door opening and closing. He missed it, though, when Entrapta exclaimed behind him: "Oh, did you see this? It's a neural interface! Non-invasive! And it probably won't fry the brain if you use it too much, either!"

They were going through the data already? He snorted. Of course they were! Carter would claim that it was a necessary check to ensure they had cracked the encryption, but he knew she wouldn't be able to resist the lure of new technology.

"Yes," Carter said. "Used to remote control drones, as far as I can tell." She looked up from her laptop - or what had been her laptop; Jack wasn't sure what she had turned it into with her tinkering - and nodded at him. "It's more advanced than our own drone technology. The data compression for the sensor feeds surpasses anything we have."

That wasn't good news. "More advanced than Ancient technology?"

Carter frowned. "Not across the band, at least, from what I can tell, sir. They are using radio, not faster than light communication, to transmit data, for example."

That was some good news, at least.

"Oh, did you see the way they do data compression?" Entrapta asked. "That's so clever! But we would have to restructure our entire computer core and crystal matrices to take advantage of it, I think… Oh, you did see it! We really need to do something about the lag."

"We'll have a meeting later today, when we're all rested, so don't geek out too much over this and get some sleep," Jack said with a grin, then made a point of yawning.

"Yes, sir." Carter had the grace to blush a little, which made her look cute, not that Jack would ever say so.

He blinked. He shouldn't be thinking that, either - he must be more tired than he had thought. "Anyway, get some sleep. It's just data, not some bomb. Is it?" Better safe than sorry.

"No, sir, it's not a bomb or a carrier for biological or chemical weapons."

He nodded. “Then we don’t have a reason to wake up the others for a meeting right now. Let’s get some real sleep.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Oh! That’s a nice drone - it’s a fighter drone! And it has energy weapons of a new design! Bulkier than bot blaster cannons, though. And it’s not space capable…” Entrapta trailed off, and Carter’s eyes darted back to her laptop.

Shaking his head, Jack turned away. What he didn’t see, he didn’t have to do anything about.

He left the room just in time to spot Catra and Melog fading into view before him. “Done?” he asked.

Catra nodded, flashing her fangs in a grin. “Of course. He slept through it.”

Melog was looking smug like a cat that got the canary.

“Good.” Jack nodded and stifled a yawn. “Meeting at… eleven,” he added. That would give Carter six hours of sleep or so.

Catra eyed the lab door. “I’ll send them to bed in a while.”

That worked as well. Jack nodded again. “Good work.”

“Of course.” She grinned and walked into the lab, and Jack headed to his temporary quarters. It was past time to get some sleep. Even with his magically healed body, he wasn’t twenty any more.

*****

Mystacor, Etheria, December 11th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Adora should be happy. Her plan was working out nicely. Everyone - almost everyone - was talking with each other. Connecting. Freely discussing important matters.

“Magic can actually heal genetic conditions. She-Ra proved that when she healed people in India,” an older sorceress said.

“That was a special occasion - she had to channel Earth’s magic as it returned to the planet.”

But the way they were talking about her as if she wasn’t present… Even Castaspella seemed to be too caught up in the discussion to realise that Adora was right here while they were discussing what she had done.

“I still say that we should call it undoing a blockade. It’s not as if she had to actually send the magic back; she just had to free it.” The older man shook his head, the thin remains of his hair moving back and forth.

“That works out the same,” the woman retorted.

“Not quite. The general result might be very similar, but how it is achieved is distinctly different. Blowing a dam isn’t the same task as carrying water up a slope to fill a river.”

“Of course, you’d use water metaphors to make a point!”

“Just because I am from Salineas originally doesn’t mean using this metaphor is wrong - water is a great metaphor for magic.”

“Can we get back to magic healing genetic conditions?” Penegal asked.

“Oh, sure. Anyway, the healing won’t turn you back into an older form of your species. Even if your older form was, ah, healthier,” the sorceress went on.

But the older man - Adora really needed to learn his name, but asking at this point would be embarrassing - disagreed. “We don’t exactly know that.”

“Humans evolved from far sturdier species.”

“But magic might not consider them healthier.”

“I think it’s a question of whether the recipient of the healing would consider an older form healthier.”

“That’s not how healing works. Magic *knows*.” Castaspella cut in.

“Etherian magic, maybe. But Earth magic works differently,” a fourth sorceress added.

Castaspella frowned. “The only differences that have been proven so far is how magic is used, not that magic works differently on Earth.”

“But you can’t exclude the possibility, can you?” Penegal leaned forward a little.

“We haven’t conducted enough experiments to determine the truth of the matter,” Castaspeall told him.

“That’s because we don’t have enough examples to investigate. Magic hasn’t been returned to enough different planets yet.”

That sounded like they blamed Adora for that. But you couldn’t just restore magic to a planet at a whim; that was dangerous. And some people might react badly to that - though, so far, the only example was Earth. She cleared her throat.

But Glimmer was quicker: “Restoring magic to a planet has to be carefully planned. We don’t want our enemies to profit from it.”

“Even if their oppressed slaves could benefit from magic returning?” the older sorceress asked.

“They could use magic to fight for their freedom!”

“Or they would be fooled into thinking magic was a gift from the Goa’uld.” Glimmer scoffed.

That was a good point.

“So…” Bow smiled. “Back to magic healing?”

“Yes. Your magic wouldn’t recognise our genome’s degradation as a defect to be cured?” Penegal sounded as if he couldn’t believe it.

“Yes.” Bow nodded. “We’ve checked Alpha’s archives - you can’t use magic to ‘heal’ a genetically engineered person from the genetic engineering.”

“That seems like an odd limit,” Freyr commented.

Glimmer shrugged. “Well, it’s not technically impossible. You could, in theory, create a spell to do that by not relying on magic guiding its power but by doing it yourself. But that would require immense research and experimenting, and the complexities of trying to alter someone genetically…” She winced.

“So, in theory, someone could create a spell that halts our genetic degradation?” Thor spoke up.

“In theory, yes,” Castaspella said. “But I don’t know anyone who could even come close to achieving such a task. And to make it work on any Asgad, and not just on a specific individual… That’s even more challenging.”

Which was apparently sorceress-speak for ‘impossible’.

“If the task is too difficult, can it be broken down into smaller tasks?” Freyr asked.

“That is also theoretically possible. But in practice, trying to combine two different spells is more complex than creating such a spell from the ground up since every spell is created individually and personally,” Castaspella said.

“On Etheria,” Penegal said.

“Yes.” Castaspella nodded at him. “It might be different on another planet.”

The Asgard exchanged glances. Adora wasn't quite sure what they were thinking - they couldn't cast spells themselves, after all.

"So, magitech can reproduce healing magic. And spells can be created for specific tasks. Combine both…" Penegal trailed off.

"...and we might be able to construct a magitech device that halts and even reverse our genetic degradation," Freyr finished for him.

"Oh!" The older sorceress perked up. "That's even more daring!"

"And even if you found trained sorceresses and magitech crafters willing to work with you on this, it would still take you a long, long time. Decades would be my guess - without a guarantee of success to begin with."

The Asgard didn't seem to consider this a problem, Adora noticed.

They are so weird, she couldn't help thinking. But the sorceresses were weird as well. So, was it really surprising that they had finally found people on Etheria that the Asgard seemed to understand and got along with?

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 11th, 1999

Samantha Carter had slept for five hours. It could have been six, but that would have required ignoring the data Entrapta and Sam had decrypted. And that would have meant she couldn't present a proper report.

At least, that was what she told herself when she hid a yawn as she set up her laptop in the briefing room the General had commandeered at Stargate Command for their team. And guarded by the special forces team he had taken with him. A sensible precaution given the scope of this… affair. Even more so after what Entrapta and Sam had discovered. Some prizes were worth a nigh-unthinkable escalation, and this prize was…

She took a deep breath as she straightened and faced the others in the room - the General, Daniel, Sha're, Catra, and Melog, all of them looking attentive. And Wilkinson and Paris, both looking as if they were not sure if they really should be here. Or wanted to be here. Well, they were here. Unlike Teal'c, who was dealing with some of the Jaffa prisoners, now that Adora couldn't visit them on short notice.

Sam nodded. "We've fully decrypted the data storage cylinder we recovered. Entrapta is currently briefing the Alliance leadership on Etheria." If Hordak had let her, at least - the former warlord had been quite firm about the need to sleep when he had cut short their data analysis this morning.

Wilkinson looked around. "And…" He cleared his throat. "What about the Alliance leadership on Earth?"

The General didn't quite smirk, but his smile was far too open to be genuine. "We'll brief High Command once we know what exactly we are facing. And Adora or Glimmer can brief the politicians."

Wilkinson and Paris exchanged a glance at that, and Sam once more had the impression that they would rather be elsewhere right now, having just realised what kind of clearance they had. They were likely imagining how harsh the punishment, should they leak any of this, would be.

But that wasn't any of her concern. She straightened. "First, the data contains descriptions and documentation of Eurondan technology and its uses, but not the schematics and documentation necessary to build or reverse-engineer any of it." The data had given both Sam and Entrapta some ideas of possible research avenues to pursue, but so had, at least in Entrapta's case, watching some Earth SciFi shows.

"Specs, not plans." The General nodded. "Advertisement."

"Bait," Catra added with a snort. "For the Russians and the Chinese."

Sam agreed with the assessment. The cylinder's content was structured like a presentation, even including combat footage, though likely carefully edited.

"So, what kind of technology are we talking about here?" the General asked. "How does it compare to ours?"

"It's generally more advanced than Earth's native technology," Sam replied. "Provided the information is factual, the weapon technology significantly surpasses whatever the Russian and Chinese can produce on every level. Advanced aircraft with energy-based weapons, neural interfaces that allow remote control of said aircraft, communication efficient and secure enough to handle combat, and energy shields that can withstand extensive bombardment. Medical technologies, including cloning and stasis pods. Drugs that rapidly accelerate healing."

The General whistled. "But no spaceships with big honking guns?"

"We've found nothing of the sort in the data available to us," Sam replied. "Generally, the data didn't contain any description or presentation of advanced technology necessary for faster-than-light travel or communication, nor space travel in general. And no magitech as far as we can tell," she added. "Though that is based on our experience with Etherian and Ancient magitech, so it's possible that some of the technology presented uses magitech based on a different magical tradition."

"Would magitech be possible in the first place without Adora restoring magic to their planets?" Daniel asked.

"They could have had relics from the time before the First Ones stole magic," Catra said. "But it's not really likely. Probably."

"And it doesn't really matter," the General said. "As long as it works for them, it would work for the Russians."

That might not be completely correct, but Sam wasn't an expert, and this wasn't the place to discuss magitech. "Compared to Horde technology, the Eurondans have advanced communication protocols. Their neural interfaces are also beyond current Horde technology." Horde Prime had been able to take control of any clone at a moment's notice, beating even what Sam had seen from the Eurondans, but that knowledge had died with him, and the Clones seemed happy to let it stay dead. Sam could understand the feeling - she wouldn't want to pursue a technology that was designed to take over her body and replace her own consciousness with someone else, either. Though she would if she had to develop a defence against it.

But that was neither here nor there right now. "The medical technology seems at least comparable, maybe superior, whereas the cloning technology and stasis pod are harder to judge; the documentation is a little scant there. All in all, Eurondan technology is generally not as advanced as Horde technology except for the aforementioned areas."

"But current NATO technology is left in the dust by this stuff." The General shook his head. "And having it would make the Russians and the Chinese a lot more powerful on Earth. They'd still lose in a standup fight, but if they started passing out such goodies to insurgents and other patsies, as they used to in the Cold War, things could turn ugly. Just the threat of that would give them a lot more influence in politics."

"And it would greatly boost their own research. Even more so if combined with access to technology recovered by Stargate Command," Sam added.

The General nodded. "Yep. They'll do anything to get this. The question is: What are the Eurondans asking for in exchange? Just raw materials, as Lenkova said was being talked about?"

"There was nothing about that in the data, sir," Sam told him. She would have included that in her briefing otherwise.

“Yeah.”

Catra suddenly tensed, cocking her head at the door. “There’s another question,” she said, showing her teeth. “What will the Russians and Chinese do if they suspect we know or might find out about their dealings? Because Lenkova is telling the guards out there that she needs to talk to Jack at once. And Melog says she’s feeling both scared and guilty. Very much so.”

The General muttered a curse under his breath.

Sam wanted to as well.

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Spy Games Part 4

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 11th, 1999

Catra watched Jack tense. Then he sighed and said: "Figures. Anyone wanna bet that this isn't good news?"

She snorted. Of course, it wasn't going to be good news. Lenkova had messed up - messed up more, to be precise.

Before anyone else could say anything, the door was opened, and Campbell peered inside, straightening when he saw Jack. "Sir? Lieutenant Lenkova says she has to speak to you urgently."

"Send her in," Jack told him.

Catra looked the woman over when Lenkova entered. She wasn't carrying a weapon - at least, Catra couldn't spot one. And she looked nervous - even glancing over her shoulder as the door closed behind her. "Is this room safe?"

"It's safe and supposed to be soundproof," Jack said. With a glance at Catra, he added: "Though no soundproofing is ever perfect."

She grinned at him. Her ears were better than the insulation here. Having a bit of warning from Melog helped, of course - she had to listen carefully to catch anything.

Lenkova looked at the others in the room, frowning at Wilkinson and Paris.

Catra lazily waved at her and flashed her fangs. She tried not to show how tense she was. If Lenkova was feeling like this, things must be worse than Catra had expected. And since she had expected the worst…

"So, what's the emergency?" Jack asked.

Lenova straightened. “Sir, I have betrayed you.”

Catra shifted on her seat. Lenkova was close enough for her to reach with one leap. And she wasn’t armoured - a few swipes with Catra’s claws, and she’d be dead.

Jack, though, didn’t blink. Nor did he draw a weapon, unlike Sha’re, who was aiming a zat straight at Lenkova.

“Where did you get that?” Catra heard Daniel whisper.

“Your Etherian friends,” Sha’re replied.

“So, how exactly did you betray me? Personally, not the thing about making contact with an unknown alien species,” Jack said.

Lenkova straightened, assuming what they called ‘parade rest’ on Earth. “After I… informed you about my country’s actions, I told Vlad… Sergeant Popov about it. About me informing you. He… disapproved.”

Popov was the other Goa’uld survivor from Lenkova’s team, Catra knew.

“Thought he’d join you, did you?” Jack asked in a soft voice.

Lenkova noded curtly. “Yes, sir. I was wrong.”

“And now the Russians know we know.” Jack sighed. “So much for surveillance.”

Sam was typing furiously on her laptop. “Sergeant Popov met with Major Baburin on the training fields.”

“Which we hadn’t bugged,” Jack said.

“You bugged the base?” For a moment, it seemed as if Lenkova’s surprise replaced her guilt.

“Of course we did. Learned that from the KGB,” Jack told her with a toothy grin that made the woman blush - probably with

embarrassment; Catra wasn't sure. "Did he know about the bugs? Or suspect it? Or was he just trying to find the major right away?" He shrugged before anyone could say anything else. "Anyway, what makes you think this was a betrayal?"

"Because they'll try to kill you, General."

Oh. Catra's eyes widened. So did Jack's. Daniel had his mouth open but wasn't saying anything. Sam looked like she wished she had a death ray powered by the Heart of Etheria at hand. And Sha're looked even more annoyed with Lenkova.

"That would be a murder attempt!" Wilkinson blurted out, then blushed when everyone, Paris and Lenkova included, stared at him. "They wouldn't dare to attack an American general in an Alliance base, would they?" he added. "That would be insane!"

"So is trying to make a deal with an alien species behind the back of the rest of Earth," Jack said. "Didn't stop them."

"Wasn't that what we were trying to do before we met the Etherians?" Daniel asked. "Make a deal, I mean."

Jack frowned at him. "Not the point, Daniel!"

Despite the situation, Catra snickered.

"They won't openly attack you - they will try to assassinate you," Lenkova said.

"Make it look like an accident?" Jack sounded perfectly calm. "Or make it a demonstration?"

Catra snorted. "Everyone would know they did it," she said.

Jack pouted at her. "I made a lot of enemies!"

"Jack!" Daniel protested.

"What?"

"That's not something to be proud of!"

"It is if it's the right sort of enemies," Jack retorted.

Catra also snickered at that. Daniel pouted, and Sam sighed softly under her breath. The others - well, except for Sha're - looked confused. Especially Lenkova. "Do you not think this is a serious threat, General?" she asked.

"Oh, I do," Jack replied, flashing his teeth. "I very much do so."

Catra grinned. It looked like she'd be able to teach the bastards responsible for stranding her on Earth a lesson, and sooner than she had thought she would.

Good, Melog thought at her.

*****

So, the Russians planned to assassinate him? Jack O'Neill bared his teeth. He wouldn't tempt Murphy by saying, 'Let them try!' but he couldn't help feeling almost glad about this - it meant that the Russians were desperate. Of course, they must have been desperate in the first place to attempt their takeover of Stargate Command. Or stupid, but the Russians Jack knew from the Cold War weren't stupid, and as far as he could tell, the old KGB spooks were calling quite a few shots in Russia. Probably literally as well.

Lenkova, though, still looked like he had just laughed in her face when she had been trying to warn him - and risking pretty much her life for it. Jack almost winced and forced himself to nod at her with a warm smile. "We're not going to underestimate them, Lieutenant. But we'll be ready for them."

"But…" Lenkova glanced at the others. "They have at least a dozen trained former KGB members here."

Including Lenkova. Jack didn't say that. Instead, he nodded. "Yes. But we've got advanced technology and magic. And we've got an

edge in experience."

"Yes," Catra said, flashing her fangs. "They won't know what hit them."

Paris looked a little… spooked. Or embarrassed, Jack noted. "I'm not actually that experienced," she said.

"Neither are the sorceresses the Russians could use against us - if they have any," Catra told her.

"And we have Kira here as support," Daniel added.

"Ah." Paris looked reassured.

"Of course, Kira is guarding the Stargate," Catra said. "So, once we leave the base, you're our sorceress."

Paris didn't look reassured any more.

"You'll do fine," Wilkinson told her. But he didn't really sound convincing to Jack. And, judging by the frown on her face, Paris agreed with him.

"Why would we leave the base?" Daniel asked.

"Because once we've dealt with whatever assassins and spies they have here," Jack explained, "we'll go after the one in charge of this plot. And that's not Sidorov." Not unless the man was a much better actor than anyone else Jack knew. And a much better spy.

"You want to go to Russia?" Lenkova blurted out.

"Or China. Or both. Depends on what we find out," Jack said. He shrugged.

"You're planning to use yourself as bait, aren't you, sir?"

Jack almost winced at Carter's frown. Right, he should have expected that. "You heard the Lieutenant. They're coming after me, so I can hardly avoid being bait." He shrugged again.

Carter's scowl deepened. "You could move back to the Alliance base - or into orbit - until we finish our investigation."

While you risk your own life? Jack gave her a look, and she had the grace to blush slightly.

Catra snorted, and Daniel sighed. "You know Jack," he said, then blinked. "I mean… I didn't mean… Ah…"

Jack's laugh cut him off. "Anyway, we've got people gunning for me. And you can bet they have all the old tools of the KGB at hand."

"So, be wary of umbrellas," Wilkinson said with a forced grin.

"Those were actually Bulgarian," Jack told him. A spook should know better.

Wilkinson frowned. "I know."

"But we cannot assume that they are limited to those tools and methods," Carter pointed out, still focused on Jack. They might have received some advanced tools from the Eurondans."

Jack nodded. Officially, or through an under-the-table deal - or just from trade between a few grunts. Soldiers always made such deals.

"And they might have some alien relics that they didn't reveal," Daniel added. "They might not have used such to take over the base's computers, but that doesn't mean they have nothing useful in an assassination."

"If it's a tool known to the Goa'uld, I'll be able to spot it," Sha're said.

Right. She had been trapped as a helpless spectator in her own body when it was taken over by Apophis's queen - she probably had seen more assassination plans and attempts than everyone else in the base together, Jack reminded himself. She wasn't the

young woman he had met during the trip to Abydos any more. He nodded again. "Good. Now, everyone, stay sharp - we'll continue our work, but we'll have to ensure we don't endanger others." Jack didn't think the Russians would shy away from collateral damage as long as it saved them from the consequences of their plots.

"We're continuously scanning for explosives, both conventional and advanced, sir," Carter said. "Also biological and chemical threats, though those scans are less dependable."

"Less dependable?" Daniel asked.

"Binary poisons are hard to detect. And bioweapons might be mistaken for normal organisms depending on how advanced they are," Carter explained.

Well, Jack hoped that the Russians were not as crazy as to use WMDs against a joint base on Canadian soil. That would… not end well at all for them no matter how it played out. "And that's why I am going to explore the area around the base," he said, "while you root out the last of the alien malware." He rolled his eyes at Daniel's open surprise - Carter hid hers much better - and added: "I do keep up with the times, Daniel."

"Of course!"

"Whatever!" Catra cut in. "Let's hash out who goes with whom. We have a general and a major to guard."

"Yep."

*****

Mystacor, Etheria, December 11th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and yes, in theory, you could probably merge a 'gene scanner' with a magitech device that casts a healing spell and rig it so it uses input from the scanner to guide the spell. But you'd have to develop everything from the ground up - we don't have that kind

of magitech device at the moment, nor do we know a healing spell that can affect genetics," Castaspella said.

Adora managed not to sigh out loud. They were still at it! Hours later! And she had thought Alliance meetings were bad!

"But magic can affect genetic conditions," Freyr said.

"She-Ra's magic, when channelling a planet's magic, can," Castaspella retorted. "That's a magic power, like a princess' power, not a spell - at least as far as we know. We haven't really analysed her power that deeply."

"We did come up with a variety of hypotheses, but we couldn't test any of them yet," the balding older man cut in with a frown aimed at Adora.

Adora met his frown. "We're in the middle of a war. Restoring a planet's magic just to run an experiment - on *my* power - has to wait."

"But it wouldn't take long at all!" the man all but whined. "And it would allow us to form a theory about this crucial aspect of Etherian magic! This could unleash a new age of research!"

"Unless your hypothesis ends up disproven," the oldest sorceress pointed out.

"Then we develop another hypothesis based on the new data!"

It was more than a little eerie how similar to Entrapta the man just sounded.

"And then we test it again," another sorceress chimed in.

Adora pressed her lips together so she wouldn't snap at the sorceresses that she wasn't at their beck and call. That would have been rude. But then, so were they.

“Are you honestly planning to replicate She-Ra’s magic?” Glimmer asked with raised eyebrows.

“Duplicate the effects, at best,” the man told her. “Replicating magic powers has proven impossible even in cases where the magic power in question seems to conform to the basic principles of spell-based magic since the underlying mechanics are completely different, but the effects often can be approximated with some research.”

“A lot of research,” the older sorceress added.

“Wait!” Adora refrained from raising her hand as if she were in a cadet training lesson. “If you can’t duplicate my power because it’s too different from spells, then why would you need to analyse it?”

“Oh, we wouldn’t need to analyse it for the project,” the man told her with a cheerful smile. “But analysing She-Ra’s magic would greatly enhance our general knowledge and understanding of magic!”

Adora glanced around and saw that all sorceresses present were nodding in agreement with him. This was…

“Princesses aren’t research subjects!” Glimmer snapped with a scowl.

“Is this a social norm, or are there factual reasons for this restriction?” Penegal asked. “Because it doesn’t seem logical to restrict magic research in that manner.”

“As I understand it, technically, princesses were research subjects of the Gate Builders - the First Ones - to start,” Freyr added.

Once more, the sorceresses nodded, and Glimmer’s scowl deepened. “Princesses are sovereigns. You ask for our help; you don’t expect it unless you’re a subject of the princess in question,” she said.

“So… would you help us?” the man asked.

Castaspella frowned at him. “Drogan!”

That was his name! Adora made a mental note.

“What? I’m just asking.”

“We shouldn’t forget that She-Ra’s magic isn’t the result of the First Ones’ experiments but predates their arrival,” Bow pointed out. “There was a She-Ra on Etheria before there were other princesses.”

“We don’t know if there were no other princesses,” the older sorceress disagreed. “There are no records in the First Ones’ research base, but we know that there were sorceresses back then, so we cannot exclude the possibility that there were magic-users that used similar principles as today’s princesses.”

“That’s your pet hypothesis. You don’t have any proof for it,” Drogan said.

“Just because you like to think that sorceresses were rulers back before the royal lines were established doesn’t mean you can dismiss my theory without any evidence!”

“It’s a hypothesis!”

“And it’s irrelevant for the project we’re discussing here,” Castaspella said. “Creating a magitech device to stop and possibly reverse the genetic degradation of the Asgard doesn’t need either.” She nodded at Bow. “But you do make a good point. We do need to determine if the effects of She-Ra’s healing magic can be duplicated by spells.”

You’re talking as if this is a done deal, Adora thought. But, seeing how the sorceresses and the Asgard acted, it probably was as good as a done deal. Everyone seemed enthusiastic, which was, of course, understandable in the case of the Asgard, but the

sorceresses of Mystacor were also very invested in the idea. Even Bow.

She looked at Glimmer. Her friend probably had realised the same thing since she was frowning in the same way she usually did when Entrapta started talking a bit too enthusiastically about some new project.

Still, it was nice to see that the Asgard had finally found common ground with at least part of Etheria.

"This will be a long undertaking, though," Castaspella went on. "We're breaking entirely new ground here. It is unclear if this will result in success."

"We're aware of that," Freyr said. "But it's the best opportunity to save our species that we've discovered."

"And if it works, we won't have to deal with Loki's scheme," Thor added.

He sounded as if that was almost as important as saving the Asgard in the first place.

And that wasn't nice, in Adora's opinion.

She blinked. They would have to tell Loki about this, and she had no idea how he would react.

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 11th, 1999

The General was using himself as bait. Typical. Samantha Carter should have expected it. She had known he'd do it as soon as Lenkova had mentioned the threat of assassination, but the possibility had been clear from the moment she had discovered that Stargate Command had been hacked. It was his style. He might claim it was just leading from the front - she had to

remember to call it ‘Princess style’ to his face next time he did so - but he was not merely leading from the front; he was deliberately exposing himself to draw fire. And he was doing it outside the base proper so that collateral damage would be minimal.

She hoped that the Russians weren’t actually as insane as attempting to assassinate a US General, a high-ranking officer in the Alliance forces and personal friend of Etheria’s most powerful leaders. Or that, if they were, they did so in a rushed and ill-prepared manner that was easily foiled, at least.

But she couldn’t dwell on this - she had a job to do. She had to root out the remnants of the programs infesting the base’s computers. They needed the Stargate operational again to transfer people to and from Etheria and other planets. Moving their only ship-mounted Stargate from its current position near the expected area of operations back to Earth would take weeks and significantly reduce the strategic mobility of the Alliance’s ‘princess squads’ and command assets. And special forces, she added after a moment.

Fortunately, she wasn’t doing this alone. Entrapta’s help was limited since she could only work through remotes, but that didn’t affect programming tasks that much. And they were making steady progress. Most peripherals were clear now, their memory scrubbed clean and reformatted or physically replaced where possible before the software was restored from clean backups. The main computer was a bit more complex, but it could be safely taken offline, and all memory purged as well. More or less safely.

The real problem was the security system. Taking it offline would render the base very vulnerable for the duration. And even isolating the different components and scrubbing them one by one would lower the efficiency of the security system as a whole since it was built with the synergy of all elements in mind. Until they had replaced all parts, they would have two partial security systems working simultaneously using different components - and they couldn’t be connected or risk reinfection of the clean components. The resulting decrease in efficiency would be

significant enough, in Sam's estimation, that a skilled and experienced operator might be able to exploit this to infiltrate critical areas of the base to conduct sabotage - or an assassination. Especially if they were already inside the base, like the Russian and Chinese agents posing as soldiers.

Of course, that would require those agents to know which subsystems were inoperational at any moment, and it wasn't as if Sam and Entrapta would announce their carefully planned schedule, but with the system already compromised, it was not impossible that the Russians and Chinese had the level of access this would require. Sam would only be able to tell after she could analyse all the programs on both the mirrored caches and the removed memory banks, at which point it would be moot one way or the other. And it wouldn't even take that to simply observe their progress and then estimate when they would be about halfway done - probably at the most vulnerable point of the entire operation.

To *safely* purge the security system, they had to install a temporary replacement. And that would take unacceptably long, as the General had made clear when Sam had mentioned it. Which left the only alternative - except gambling that the Russians and Chinese wouldn't risk doing exactly what Lenkova had warned the General about - trusting guards and other ad-hoc measures to take up the slack.

Sam didn't like it. But the General did. He was actually hoping that the Russians would attempt something - would try to assassinate him! - and expose themselves in the process.

She gritted her teeth at his foolish risk-taking - he was a general now, not a colonel any more, and no matter what Etherian princesses did, generals weren't supposed to 'lead from the front' like this. Hadn't been supposed to since the 19th century!

But she was wasting time, crucial time, again. She had a main computer to purge of all spyware. They had removed the memory banks completely already, but the caches and internal memory of

the core remained. Sam would prefer to replace the entire core, but General Hammond had blanched at the cost of the replacement, and even the General had agreed.

Of course, he had agreed by stating that he trusted Sam to clean up the core, she reminded herself, smiling softly for a moment before frowning at her foolishness and focusing again on the task in front of her.

"Anyone want a sandwich?" Catra's voice interrupted her. "The tuna sandwiches are mine, but I got pastrami, cucumber, eggsalad and some 'croque monsieur', which is French for 'cheese sandwich' as far as I can tell."

Sam was about to ignore Cara - who should be guarding the General, not her, no matter what the General thought - but the woman held a plate entirely too close to Sam's face, and the scent of fresh bread and cheese hit her nose and made her stomach remind her that she hadn't eaten in a while.

Which Catra must have been aware of, judging by her smug smile when Sam grabbed a sandwich. Damn her.

"So, how's it going?" Catra asked, munching on a tuna sandwich as she sat down on the table next to Sam's temporary desk, tail and legs dangling.

"As projected," Sam replied.

"That bad, huh?" Catra grinned.

"It's going well," Entrapta chimed in, lagging again.

Catra nodded. "Jack's outside, 'inspecting' the snow still. I don't think…"

Sam looked up. Catra had gone tense, and her ears were twitching as she cocked her head to the door.

No, to Melog, who had gotten up from where they had been sprawled on the floor.

Something was up, and Sam was sure it wasn't anything good.

*****

Danger.

Yeah, no shit, Catra thought, her ears twitching as she listened to the discussion outside the room between a Chinese scientist and the guards stationed there. The man was claiming that he needed access to the computer for his research, and he was acting as if he wasn't aware of the current tension between the Chinese and Russian contingents and the rest of Stargate Command, but his 'absent-minded, research-focused' manner felt very suspicious.

But he was alone and facing not just a fire team from SG-3 but a team of Jack's special forces as well, and she couldn't really hear anyone else nearby, so even if he was a spy or assassin, what was he planning to do when outnumbered like that? Against alert guards? Even for a princess, that could be tricky.

Hurting.

The man was hurting? "What?" Catra muttered under her breath.

"What's going on?" Sam asked.

"Huh?" Daniel looked up from the book he had been reading, but Sha're had already drawn her zat.

"Trouble?" Wilkinson asked, putting his hand on his gun, like Paris.

"Yes," Catra replied. "But not sure what kind. One Chinese 'scientist' is arguing with the soldiers outside, and he's hurting…" How? And why?

"What's going on?" Entrapta asked, lagging.

Catra ignored her friend - Entrapta's question was answered already.

Others hurting now!

Melog's urgent message came a moment before Catra heard the groans - and the falling bodies. What the… Her eyes widened while she was moving towards the door. "Poison!"

"Poison? We haven't cleared the sensors for…" Sam trailed off. "They must have taken them over! But my scanner should have detected it!"

"Poison gas?" Daniel blurted out.

"Prolly," Catra replied. None of the soldiers outside had managed to get a shot off, so that was some nasty gas.

She was at the door now. It should be airtight, but…

"Gas is more efficient than poisoning the food and drinks unless you are after a single target," Sha're said, joining her.

Catra heard a series of unfamiliar but identical noises outside. "He's shooting the soldiers," she snapped.

"Poison?" Entrapta's gasp was drowned out by the sound of an alarm going off inside the entire base - Sam's work, no doubt. Chemical attack warning, Catra realised.

"That means the door is next," Sha're said in a clipped voice. "And the gas is still outside."

"I shut down the climate controls, but if they sabotaged the system…" Sam trailed off. "The core rooms are compartmentalised, but the main part of the base…" She started typing on the console but drew back after a second. "They shut down the controls!"

“Would they attack the base with gas?” Daniel sounded shocked. “I mean, the entire base?”

“No sign of that,” Sam reported, fingers flying over her keyboard.

No hurting outside.

With the alerts still sounding, it was hard to follow the action outside. Catra couldn’t track the spy’s steps any more. But she knew what he was doing. “Back away from the door!” she snapped, moving to the side.

A moment later, an explosion shattered the door, and Catra’s ears rang. She had to stop herself from leaping through the smoking hole - there was gas outside. Coming inside.

Then she felt a breeze from behind - and heard Paris chanting shakily.

Magic wind.

Catra grinned, baring her fangs. That was quick thinking! She looked at Melog. “Do your thing!”

Melog cocked their head to the side for a moment, then Catra saw the room change, people vanishing, replaced by figures writhing on the floor as her friend’s illusion took hold.

“Overpressure! Keep the gas out!” Entrapta yelled on the screen. “Reverse flow on the climate controls!”

Oh. Catra’s friend hadn’t noticed what was going on - this was bad.

But they couldn’t stop. Catra loudly groaned, faking pain. The others chimed in, some more, some less convincing.

And then a figure stepped through the fading smoke, holding an unknown weapon in one hand and an alien cylinder in the other.

Sha're's zat dropped him before he could do anything, and Catra quickly secured him - holding her breath just in case. She couldn't hear any hissing noise, so there was no gas being released here, but better safe than sorry.

"No! Get up! Help! Hel… Oh!" Entrapta's frantic, desperate voice trailed off as Melog's illusion faded again.

"It was an illusion," Sam explained. "But the gas is real."

"And I'm not sure how much longer Paris can keep her magic breeze going," Wilkinson commented.

Catra glanced at the FBI sorceress. She looked like she was struggling. Severely struggling.

"We have to get out of here!" Catra yelled. But that would take them through the invisible poison cloud outside.

"I'm clearing the ventilation," Sam said. "The filters cannot be circumvented by remote controls. But I cannot predict if they will work on the gas used. My scanner didn't detect it."

Damn. Catra gritted her teeth. They were trapped inside the room. And Paris wouldn't last much longer.

"Can you build protection gear?" Entrapta asked.

"And I can't raise the General on the radio!" Sam added.

That was bad news, but Catra couldn't really afford to worry about Jack right now.

They had to find a way out of this death trap!

Wait! The assassin - he wasn't wearing a gas mask or a suit. He must have been immunised to the gas - partially, at least. He had been hurting. So, that wouldn't help them either. But… "Can you track the gas with your scanner?"

“I’ll need to tweak it, but if I enhance it, it should be able to detect any particles.” Sam was already fiddling with her scanner.

“Can you fix the door? With the desk? And using a sealant?” Entrapta suggested, still lagging.

“Done!” Sam announced. “Tracking unknown particles…” She drew hissing breath. “The entire hallway outside is filled with the gas. The other hallways are clear.”

No choice. “Use your magic to push the gas into a corner in the hallway,” Catra told Paris. “So we can get to the door.”

“Can you do it?” Wilkinson asked.

She has to, Catra thought. Or they were done for.

Shakingly, Paris nodded.

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Training Grounds, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 11th, 1999

As soon as he heard the alert, Jack O’Neill reached for his gas mask, reflexes reaching back to boot camp taking over. Chemical Attack! Gas! Mask on!

But he wasn’t carrying a gas mask! He wasn’t even carrying his full field kit!

Before he could do more than curse, Isa almost slapped him in the face with a mask. “Sir!”

The sergeant had already masked up - as had Campbell. Jack had picked his people well.

So, instead of making a comment about always having known that a desk job would be his death, he slipped the mask on. “Thank you. I somehow doubt that this is a drill.”

"Yes, sir." Isa wasn't looking at him. The huge woman had her machine gun shouldered and was scanning for threats together with her partner.

Jack quickly glanced around, but he couldn't spot anything or anyone, and his radio was quiet - jammed? He pulled his communicator out. "Carter?"

"Under attack, sir. Chemical."

Jack drew a sharp breath as he felt his stomach clench. Then rage filled him. If the Russians had gassed Carter - and the base - he'd nuke their country from orbit! Priest would do it, anyway - Catra was with Carter, and killing Her Holyness's Holy Consort or whatever would certainly earn divine retribution!

No! He was better than that. And personally hunting down everyone responsible for this would be far more satisfying, anyway. "Sitrep."

"We're temporarily containing the gas and are moving to a safe area of the base," Carter reported.

Jack let out a breath he hadn't realised he was holding. They were safe. Safeish.

"There were casualties, though. The guards assigned to us were shot."

Damn. Jack looked at his two guards - now the only survivors of the squad he had taken with him. "Gas attack inside the base. Someone shot Brandis and his team."

The masks hid their expressions, but he could see them tense.

"We've captured the attacker."

Only one attacker? But they had been using gas. Still… Jack would have to review procedures. "Keep me informed. We're returning to base."

"Yes, sir. Passing into a secure area now."

Good. Jack glanced at Isa and Campbell again. "We're going back. Stay sharp. If they attacked the others, they won't be planning to let us be." The Russians would have to be complete fools if they thought they could get away with killing Jack's team without taking him out as well. Of course, the Russians would have to be complete fools to believe they could get away with this attack at all.

This has the scent of a hasty, improvised operation, Jack thought as they started to walk back towards the main entrance to Stargate Command's compound. Someone must have panicked when we started unravelling their plot.

That was both good and bad news. They had to expect anything now, even insane attempts at taking the entire base. Jack froze for a moment. Would the Russians start a war over this? He didn't think so, but he wouldn't have thought they'd use a chemical weapon in Stargate Command, either. Hell, that was already risking a war. So was what he was about to do, but he didn't see any way around it.

Switching channels, he contacted the task force guarding Earth's orbit. "O'Neill here. We're under attack by unknown forces, suspected to be Russian and Chinese in origin. Prepare to repel any military attacks against Alliance countries."

"Yes, General!"

If Jack was wrong, he might have just sunk his career. And possibly started a war. Well, he could always emigrate to Etheria. There was bound to be a nice spot in the mountains somewhere there with room for a hut and a lake for fishing.

Snorting, he pushed the thought away and focused on the area ahead of them. Survival first, future later. The roads and the main paths were clear of snow, but the rest of the area was covered with it. That meant anyone trying to attack or ambush them was

either limited in where they moved or had to deal with leaving tracks.

But the Russians had experience with that. Canada wasn't Siberia, but snow was snow. Mostly. And while they were inside the base area, few people were outside at this time, so an assassin wouldn't have to dodge - or deal with - too many people. There were patrols, of course, but they were focused on keeping threats away, not hunting down assassins inside the base. Still, an assassin wouldn't want to get too close to the perimeter. That limited the approaches they could take.

"Watch the small ridge ahead," Jack called out. "Good ambush spot."

"Yes, sir." Isa twisted her upper body a bit and aimed her machine gun at it.

Campbell moved to cover the other side, where a field was currently serving as a snow dumping spot. A decent spot to set up crossfire, but you'd have to climb the mound of snow and expose yourself. Or you'd have to burrow through it…

"Stop!" Jack snapped, dropping to the ground and quickly moving behind a heavy chest full of snow-clearing gear stashed nearby. Using binocs with a gas mask on was annoying but not impossible. And it beat discovering an ambush by walking into it.

He scanned the piled-up snow. This was a hasty attack - they wouldn't have had time to prepare much, if at all. And they would have been under pressure not to miss Jack and his team before they returned to base. So… He studied the upper parts of the mound, hoping that whoever was out there wasn't lining up a shot at him right now. The snow was riddled with sticks and darker stones, which didn't help. But Jack knew someone was there. He just had to find them.

There! That wasn't a stick - that was a barrel! AK-style!

Jack bared his teeth. “Sniper nest. Ten yards to the left from the top of the mound. Isa.”

“Got it,” Isa replied as she and Campbell switched sectors.

A moment later, she started firing, the machine gun’s bursts ripping through the snow. Even densely packed, you needed a lot of snow to stop a heavy machine gun - and Isa was an excellent shot.

“Contact ridge!” Campbell yelled. He was already firing.

Jack ducked down and made a note to start carrying something heavier than a pistol. He still shot back at what looked like two people with assault rifles but didn’t think he hit either. Not before Campbell and Isa, who swung her gun around, cut both down.

Almost literally, in her case. No need to check for survivors there.

By the time the first patrol - a squad from SG-3 - arrived a few minutes later, they had found the sniper in the mound as well. A burst from Isa had gone through his torso, showering the snow tunnel he had dug with blood and gore, but the head was intact enough to identify Sergeant Popov.

Damn. Lenkova would blame herself for this. Even if it wasn’t her fault at all - she had done the right thing.

His communicator announced an incoming call. “O’Neill!” he snapped, looking around.

“Stand by for Her Divine Highness,” a clone told him.

Oh. Of course, Priest would have informed Adora. And, of course, Adora would be calling him at once. From Etheria. With all the delay in communication that caused.

Damn.

"Jack." Adora sounded very tense. *"What's going on? Catra said they were safe, but she had Russians to fight. And Priest is asking for permission to prepare an orbital bombardment."*

Oh! "It's not like that!" Jack replied. "Russians and Chinese attacked us in Stargate Command, so I asked him to be ready to deal with attacks on the Alliance by either country. Just in case."

Seconds passed.

"Good. They have firing solutions ready for every Russian and Chinese military installation they know of."

Jack was pretty sure they had firing solutions for any known military installation on Earth, including the Alliance bases. But that was just standard procedure. "We're sorting this out here," he told her.

"Get the Stargate open again. I need to come to Earth as soon as possible."

Jack knew better than to argue that. And with Priest sounding so trigger-happy, the sooner they could get Adora to Earth, the better. "Will do."

He left the patrol to deal with the rest and hurried back to the base. He had to check up on his team. And the Russians and Chinese needed to be dealt with.

But when they reached the entrance to the base proper, he could see that things were already, if not in hand, then getting done. A squad of Chinese soldiers - disarmed - was led out of the base under armed guard.

"What's the status of the base?" Jack barked. Stargate Command wasn't under Alliance command, but he was the one with the direct line to the spaceships in orbit with the big honking spaceguns, and members of the Alliance had been killed with a chemical weapon, so he doubted that anyone would try to pull rank on him.

The French Lieutenant straightened. "We're securing the prisoners in a 'angar without direct access to the base, General," he replied in slightly accented English.

"Is the Stargate secure?" Jack asked. The Chinese looked… not mulish but stoic, despite not being dressed for the outside. He couldn't see any wounds or other signs of having fought amongst them or the French soldiers, either.

"Yes, General." The Lieutenant nodded. "The Chinese surrendered without a fight when General Haig ordered them to. The Russians… resisted and had to be subdued."

Jack nodded. He would have to ask Hammond for more information. "Carry on."

"Yes, General."

They stepped into the lift, and Jack used his communicator again. "Carter, we're coming down. Had a little scuffle with Russians trying to stop us. Status?"

"We're in the control centre, sir." Carter sounded relieved. *"General Haig ordered the Russian and Chinese troops to lay down their arms and surrender. General Li complied. General Sidorov ordered his soldiers to resist before General Haig stunned him. Some are still holding out in their barracks."*

"Not for long, I hope."

"I don't expect them to, sir. Catra and Melog are assisting Stargate Command with securing the base."

"Copy that." Good. It seemed things were under control. At least inside Stargate Command.

The lift arrived, and Isa moved in front of Jack before the doors opened. He didn't argue with her either. Never give an order you know won't be obeyed.

But the hallways were secure - a British squad was covering all doors.

Inside the control centre, Carter was busy at her computer, with Daniel and Sha’re standing a bit to the side, whispering to each other, and Wilkinson hovering near Paris, who was sitting on the ground, leaning against the wall, looking like she had just ran a marathon or two.

That… “Don’t tell me that they also attacked you with magic!” Jack blurted out.

“No, Jack,” Daniel replied. “But Agent Paris had to use a lot of magic to contain the gas so we could pass through safely.”

Paris nodded weakly. “It drained me more than expected.”

“It was enough to save us all,” Sha’re said.

She had saved his team? Jack would have to make sure she joined his command. Or at least the Alliance.

But first, he reminded himself as he turned towards Hammond, he had to sort out this mess. Preferably without starting a war, but he wasn’t particularly picky about that right now.

*****

Spy Games Part 5

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 12th, 1999

Adora could barely keep from running down the ramp when she arrived on Earth. Finally! After hours of doing nothing while Sam and Entrapta worked on the Stargate computers, worrying while she waited for the all-clear… But she was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance. She couldn't rush into this like some worried girl.

Jack was there, as were Generals Haig and Hammond, and Isa and… Sergeant Campbell, and that was Kira in the background.

"Supreme Commander." Jack saluted her, followed by the other generals.

She returned the salute.

Before she could say anything, Entapta arrived behind her and rushed down the ramp - and past them. "Hi, everyone! Bye, everyone - I'll be in Sam's lab!" And then she was out the door, leaving everyone else blinking.

"Good to have you back," Jack said with a grin as he lowered his hand.

"Good to be back. Glimmer was held up but will join us in a while." Once she and Bow had explained things to Loki. Adora glanced around. Where was Catra? She hadn't been hurt while taking down the last Russians, Adora knew that, but why wasn't she here? She wouldn't care about proper procedure, either… "So, what did you find out about the attack?"

Jack didn't mention that his latest report had been sent an hour ago and nodded. "We're still interrogating the prisoners. Sidorov is staying silent, as is Li, and most of everyone else is claiming to have merely followed orders."

She snorted at that. “And the assassin you caught alive?”

“Under guard in the infirmary.”

Was that where Catra was? Standing guard so the prisoner wouldn’t be murdered to silence him?

Jack shrugged and went on: “It looks like he was using some alien drugs to keep the alien gas he was also using from harming him too much. But when Sha’re stunned him, he couldn’t use the drug any more, and…

“I can heal him,” Adora said. “I can heal all wounded.”

“That would be appreciated,” General Haig said.

Right. This was Stargate Command, not an Alliance base. Adora had been a bit rude by talking to Jack, hadn’t she? “It’s the least I can do,” she told him. She glanced around. They were almost at the door leading out of the gate room, and she couldn’t see any sign of Catra. “Let’s head to the infirmary first, then. No need to let our wounded suffer any longer.”

“This way,” Hammond said, gesturing down the hallway.

“Are the Russians and Chinese leaders still claiming that this was done by rogue soldiers?” Adora asked.

“That’s their story, and they’re sticking to it. For now,” Jack replied. “Li hasn’t refuted that - he commented that a scheme to smuggle alien goods through the gate would have made him and Sidorov a fortune.”

Hammond scoffed at that.

Adora frowned as well. “And Sidorov is staying silent?”

“Probably waiting for orders from Russia,” Jack said. “The whole attack smells rushed and improvised. Never a good combination.”

Hammond coughed loudly, and Jack pouted at him.

"We can count ourselves lucky that they apparently lacked proper planning and support," Haig said. "Albeit, I assume that they had contingency plans worked out in advance."

"Which Carter and the others wrecked when they started poking around, I bet:" Jack grinned.

Adora nodded - Sam and Entrapta rooting through the compromised computer memory banks would have likely spoilt some plans.

They reached the infirmary. No Catra in sight, but Melog was curled up in front of a room with two guards next to the door. They looked at her, yawned and curled up again.

So, Catra was fine. But still missing.

Adora quickly healed the wounded - about a dozen, ranging from lightly hurt to having caught a few bullets - then headed to the room where the assassin was held.

Two more guards stood to each side of the bed there, and the prisoner was tied down as well. He looked pretty bad - he had tubes running into his mouth and nose, and his skin had a greyish tone.

"Can't have him suicide, should he wake up," Jack said. "But he's stable as far as we can tell. The Doc says they're still analysing the poison gas, but a lot of it broke down already."

She nodded and healed the man. He remained asleep, or so it seemed - but she caught him tense just a bit. "We know you're awake," she said.

He didn't react. Ah, well… She glanced at Jack. "We can start interrogating him."

"I'll inform our specialist."

Their specialist? Did he mean Wilkinson? Probably.

"We've prepared a meeting room," Hammond said. "Unless you have to travel to Brussels immediately."

Without Catra? Adora almost snapped at him. She managed to nod. "No, we've got a few things to discuss."

And a cat to find. She was getting worried again. Even though Melog would have shown if Catra was hurt. Or in danger. But she couldn't help…

"Hey, Adora."

Adora whirled. There, leaning against the wall outside the infirmary, was Catra! Smirking like… well, her.

"Catra!"

"Yeah. Finally made it back here, huh? About…"

"Catra!" Adora's hug cut off her lover's next words. And then her kiss cut off any protests.

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 12th, 1999

Samatha Carter cleared her throat as she stepped up to the big holographic screen in the meeting room the Alliance had taken over inside Stargate Command. "Supreme Commander. General. Commander." She nodded at Adora, the General and Glimmer, then at the others present. "We've finished our preliminary analysis of the recovered alien technology." Very preliminary. She wished she was better prepared for this - between the need to clear the base's computers and ensure there were no boobytraps left by saboteurs so they could reopen the Stargate, she hadn't had a lot of time to examine the alien technology they had secured. That wasn't long enough to draw solid conclusions.

Although Entrapta had joined her as soon as they had opened the wormhole again, followed later by Bow, and between them, they had managed at least to get a decent overview of the various pieces. And realise how close we had come to dying, she added in her mind - Entrapta hadn't reacted particularly well to that. Not after having seen her friends dying from the poison gas and communication lag preventing her from realising it was one of Melog's illusions for several seconds. Catra hadn't taken that well - she hadn't realised how her plan would look to Entrapta.

But sorting that out could wait. She had a briefing to do. She pressed a key on her laptop, and the projection of a small cylinder appeared on the screen, slowly rotating around itself. "This is the container that carried the poison gas used against us by Qiang Lee." They hadn't yet found out whether the assassin they had captured was Dr Quiang Lee, a young astrophysicist who had published several works or a soldier impersonating him - the man had refused to answer any questions, last Sam heard. "It is shielded from any conventional sensors we know on Earth, though not from magic or Ancient sensors," she explained.

"Then how could they smuggle it into the base?" Glimmer asked, frowning deeply.

"Because the compound contained inside the cylinder is not poisonous until it reacts with human biochemistry. It's like a binary poison where one component is a part of the human body. The poison so produced acts like a standard poison, but since it is generated upon contact, our scanners didn't pick it up until it started taking effect. And even then, the scanner focused on the poison created, not the compound in the air." Even the magic scanner had been fooled by this, which Sam suspected was accidental, but they couldn't rule out that the Eurondans used magic themselves.

"Which we have corrected now!" Entrapa chimed in. "And we've adjusted the scanner to show any unknown particles - though that will make it probably overly sensitive to many harmless

substances on alien planets, so… We might have to be careful about that."

"We'll get false alerts for a while," the General summed up.

"Yes, sir. We suggest that a dedicated crew of technicians and scientists is part of any force landing on a new planet to speed up such adjustments," Sam told him.

"Making the scanner adjust to that automatically is kinda difficult," Entrapta said with a pout. "We'd have to give it the same databanks and sensor capability Alpha has, and that would make it hard to fit into a portable scanner. Though for a fleet action, we could have a special ship with a lab on board to analyse any such data transmitted from the surface!"

"A science vessel in the fleet?" The General snorted. "I guess Star Trek will be vindicated."

Sam narrowed her eyes at him - slightly. "It is the same concept of having scientists as part of an exploration team." That had been her own position in SG-1!

"Right." He looked a little sheepish for a moment before nodding at her.

"The poison is a neural agent attacking the central nervous system of anyone exposed to it. The effect is debilitatingly painful but would take quite some time to kill a victim."

The others in the room looked shocked or grim at the news - and with cause. It was a very cruel way to kill someone. It was almost a mercy that Lee had killed the teams he had used the gas against. Almost.

The General nodded again. "That's the gas. And the gun?"

"It's a direct energy weapon of unknown make," Sam told him as the gun appeared on the screen. "Definitely alien in origin. The

gun's velocity is relatively slow, but it can damage both organic and inorganic targets and has a stun setting."

"Like a zat?" Catra asked.

"It follows a similar concept, but it works differently," Sam corrected her. "It causes direct physical or stun damage."

"And it didn't show up on our scanner either?" The General raised his eyebrows.

"The power source was not powerful enough to show up on the general scan," Sam explained.

That had the General snort. "Figures it was something like that."

Sam could see the irony, but they had lost two squads to this weapon and the gas. "We also secured this." She showed another, smaller cylinder. "It's a medical device - it works similar to an autoinjector. We first assumed that the substance was an antidote for the poison, but it's actually a medical compound that very quickly heals the body once administered. Quickly enough that Lee didn't succumb to the gas even though he was exposed to it for a length of time."

"But it hurt him," Catra said, "Melog felt it."

"Yes." Sam nodded. Lee must have been suffering horrible pain throughout the fight.

The General frowned. "That does sound like he was improvising. If he had prepared this beforehand, he probably would have had an antidote ready. And how much of that stuff was the assassin carrying?"

"Half a dozen injectors, sir," Sam replied.

The General looked at her, then at the others. "That wasn't an assassination attempt. He wanted hostages."

That was a likely conclusion, indeed.

“Hostages?” Adora scowled.

“Me.” Catra hissed. “To use against you.”

“It would make the whole attempt to take over the base a little less insane,” the General went on, looking at Catra and Adora. “Still not sane, but if they thought taking you hostage would stay your hand…” He shrugged.

Sam nodded. Everyone knew that the Etherians treated politics as a personal affair. If the Chinese - and the Russians, since they had been working together - thought that meant they would value friends above everything else… Well, they weren’t entirely wrong, but they would have completely miscalculated how the Etherians would respond to such a ploy.

And, Sam added with a slight wince when she saw Adora, Catra and the other Etherians’ expressions, they might end up finding out exactly how wrong they had been - and how right.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 13th, 1999

Usually, meetings in the Alliance Headquarters were dominated by the military. This time, there were far fewer military uniforms visible than usual, Catra noticed. Instead, more people wore suits. And humans insisted that these weren’t civilian uniforms even though every Earth ruler seemed to be wearing them!

She snorted as she sat down next to Adora. Not every ruler was attending, but the most important ones were here - the ones from Britain, France, Germany, the United States and Canada, though the last one’s importance was questionable, according to Jack. Still, the Stargate was on their soil. Or surrounded by their soil, depending on how you interpreted the international treaty covering it. Catra wasn’t a lawyer, but if you lost the right to rule a

piece of your land and other kingdoms had free access to it and could station what troops they wanted there, it wasn't your land any more, was it?

Not that it mattered. This would be decided by the leaders of the Alliance, and that only because Adora was, again, being a goody-two-shoes about the rules.

"Alright," Adora spoke up. "You've all received the preliminary report about the attacks on Stargate Command. Do you have any questions?"

She looked formidable, all serious and angry, and Catra felt a shiver run down her spine. Her love.

Most of the people present shook their heads, and after a moment, Adora went on: "We've lost four Alliance soldiers killed in action. Stargate Command lost ten soldiers killed in action and fifteen wounded. No civilians were hurt or killed during the chemical attack."

"An attack with an alien gas weapon," the Canadian Prime Minister said. "That is a war crime. They attacked us."

"Russia and China are claiming this was the result of actions taken by officers going rogue," the German Bundeskanzler said. "Given the current state of relations with the United Nations, disproving that claim could prove tricky."

"What you mean is that too many countries in the United Nations are ruled by bigots and dictators who fear and resent the Alliance and would never rule in our favour no matter what proof we have," Glimmer said with a slight sneer.

Catra wasn't the only one who snorted at that.

The German nodded, apparently not fazed. "Exactly. Even if Russia and China didn't have veto powers, the odds of achieving support by the United Nations for our response are not good."

“We don’t need their support,” Glimmer retorted. “We can destroy the Russian and Chinese military from orbit without trouble.”

Catra saw the other rulers tense at that. They must have known that, though - the Alliance knew what Horde frigates could do and how good the Alliance scanners were. Their military was planning to use orbital fire support for planetary invasions, even!

“But if we do this, other countries might be driven to similarly desperate actions,” the German Bundeskanzler said. “They would remember the intervention in Iran as well. Can we afford such ‘distractions’ during wartime?”

“And even part of the public in our own countries might not react favourably to what they might see as a disproportionate retaliation,” the British Prime Minister pointed out.

Catra overheard the British Admiral muttering something about “another General Belgrano”, but she had no idea what he meant.

“We were attacked with chemical weapons! Our soldiers were murdered!” the Canadian Prime Minister retorted. “I doubt that anyone sane will dispute that this requires a reaction.”

“The problem is that the whole attack was so insane, many people won’t believe that Russia or China could do this,” the British Prime Minister said. “And, as the report states, the whole attack seemed to have been an improvised and panicked reaction to the discovery of their takeover of the Stargate Command main computer.” He looked around, “Can we really dismiss the possibility that this was decided and executed by officers acting on their own?”

“Russia and China are still responsible for their forces. If they cannot control them, then that’s on them,” the French Président said.

The US President looked a little doubtful. “We cannot actually tell if the trade deals with the aliens were authorised by the Russian president, much less the escalation to attempted assassination.

He will be replaced at the end of the month, and by all accounts, he has not been in control of his government for quite some time, with oligarchs instead struggling for power in the wake of First Contact. What the new president will do is anyone's guess."

"China has no such excuse," the Canadian Prime Minister retorted. "And the attack with chemical weapons was done by a Chinese agent posing as a scientist."

"They are saying that this is proof that the man is a rogue spy and criminal," the Bundeskanzler cut in.

"We have had reports about internal struggles from China, but nothing concrete," the US President said. "But it is unlikely that they were so compromised that rogue elements could infiltrate their troops and scientists at Stargate Command."

Catra nodded in agreement. That was nonsense. Even if a number of countries would claim to believe it.

"But why would they do something so insane?" the Bundeskanzler asked. "They must have known that even if they had taken hostages, they wouldn't have gotten away with it - and if they had made any demands, they would have had to abandon the claim that this wasn't done on the orders of their governments."

"They're paranoid and desperate," Jack spoke up. "The Russians have convinced themselves for decades that NATO wants to attack them. I doubt the Chinese have forgotten the Korean War. And now their military has been rendered obsolete - they know that; don't think they haven't spies in places - and they know what they would do in our place. So, even an insane plan might look better to them than their current situation."

Catra pressed her lips together. She knew about risking everything on a slim chance of victory instead of accepting defeat. She had almost destroyed Etheria as a result. But that didn't excuse it - or her own actions.

"That doesn't excuse their actions," Adora said, repeating Catra's thought.

"And they cannot be allowed to get away with this, or they'll try the same thing again - and so will everyone else," Glimmer added.

"No matter if they're actually guilty or not," Jack said.

"The buck stops with them," the US President added. He seemed to agree with Jack, even if Catra didn't get the reference.

"So," Adora spoke up. "What do you suggest we do?"

Several of the people present tensed up again, Catra noted.

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Jack O'Neill raised his eyebrows a little at the wording. 'Suggest' - Adora didn't make it sound as if she was humouring the politicians present, but he had no doubt that if she didn't like a suggestion, she'd ignore it.

The question was: Were the politicians aware of that? They should; the President had had a lot of briefings from Jack and his team about the Etherians, and Jack was sure that the other leaders had been briefed by their people. And they had been working with the Princesses for over a year now. But the Etherians hadn't really thrown their power around as they could have, and Adora and her friends had been primarily working with the military staff, not the civilian leaders.

"First, we need to know if we have proof that this was an organised attack by Russia and China," the Bundeskanzler said. "Our response has to take into account how much support we have amongst our allies and the public. There's also the question of how NATO is handling this."

Glimmer rolled her eyes. Probably barely holding back a cynical comment about the free press, Jack thought. Or daytime TV.

Catra leaned forward. “The assassin isn’t talking. If you want proof, we need to go and capture the Russian and Chinese leadership and see if they talk.”

The Bundeskanzler drew back, and his eyes widened at that.

“That would not be received well by many other countries,” the French Président said. “Especially not in Africa, Asia and Central America.”

“You mean primarily the countries where the former colonial powers continued to topple governments they didn’t like?” Daniel asked. “Including the United States.”

“Yes.” The French Président nodded with a slight smile.

Jack snorted. You could almost admire the way the French shamelessly owned up to it. The President, on the other hand, was wincing, and the British Prime Minister looked like he had bitten into a lemon. He half-expected the Canadians and Germans to claim they weren’t involved in any of that, but neither did.

“The Stargate was attacked with a chemical weapon,” the Canadian Prime Minister repeated himself instead. “Soldiers of Stargate Command but also Alliance soldiers died as a result. And it was done by Russians and Chinese using technology and weapons from an unknown alien power. I think this will speak for itself, at least in our countries.”

“If we present it like that, focus on the brave soldiers uncovering the infiltration and fighting off the insidious attack…” The President nodded. “The media will like it. It’s almost a Pearl Harbour moment.”

Jack pressed his lips together. Those had been his people who had died, both Special Operations Command and SG-3. They hadn’t died for the optics of this. But saying so wouldn’t help things right now. Even if he really wanted to.

“So, that covers the support from your people,” Glimmer said, not quite rolling her eyes to make sure everyone understood what she thought about the whole thing. “But what do you suggest we should do?”

“What do you suggest?” the Bundeskanzler asked. For a moment, he looked as if he was surprised by his own question, in Jack’s impression. It was a fair question, though, even if it would have been sassy coming from someone else - like Jack.

“We need to ensure that they will not launch another such attack against us,” Glimmer replied. “We don’t know if they have more of the poison gas and the other alien technology the assassin used.”

“They wouldn’t dare, would they?” The Bundeskanzler said. “Their excuses are already threadbare thin. Another attack with either poison gas or alien technology would be a clear act of war - against the entire Alliance and NATO..”

That was debatable, as far as Jack understood the issue. The Alliance was aimed against the Goa’uld, not other countries on Earth; the Princesses had made it clear that they didn’t want to be dragged into internal conflicts on Earth. But Alliance soldiers had been attacked, and aliens were - directly or indirectly - involved, and that made it Alliance business. Of course, an attack against a NATO country could trigger Article Five.

“If they are as desperate - and paranoid - as Jack said, then what do they have to lose?” Catra shrugged. “If they expect us to crush them, we might as well do it before they cobble together another attack. Nukes and gas we can stop, but what if they have biological weapons?”

That was a horrible possibility. Jack had seen the data about Ancient bioweapons. If the Russians and Chinese had something comparable…

“If they had that capability, I’d expect them to threaten us with it,” the British Prime Minister said. “At least through diplomatic

channels."

"They might not think it would be worth losing the element of surprise in case the Etherians are willing to sacrifice Earth to destroy them," the French Président retorted.

Adora and her friends gasped. "We would never do that!" she blurted out.

Glimmer nodded emphatically. "It would be a betrayal of everything the Alliance stands for!"

Jack grimaced. "We know that. But the Russians and Chinese would do it in your place." At least their leaders, as far as Russia had a leader at the moment. Which was another can of worms - if the Russian leadership was dysfunctional… "Whatever we do, we need to know what technology the Russians and Chinese have at their disposal," he said.

Everyone agreed to that. "But the prisoners aren't talking," Adora said. "The most they say, some of them, is that they were following orders and defending themselves. And as long as they don't talk even Kira's Truth spells won't really help."

There was a solution for getting people to talk, Jack knew, but it wasn't a solution the Etherians would condone. And since they needed their sorceresses for the truth spells, the solution was off the table.

Which was a relief - Jack really didn't want to torture prisoners. And letting others do it wasn't any better - worse, actually.

But that didn't change the fact that they needed more information. He could only hope that his people working on it would come up with something.

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 13th, 1999

“Da, following orders is Russian way. If you follow orders of superior, you do no wrong even if you do wrong. Unless, of course, superior or superior’s superior disagrees.”

Iwan was a good scientist and had quite the charm - Samantha Carter might even consider him a friend, if not a close friend - but his English was really annoying. Doubly so since she was certain that he could speak far better English yet chose to talk like this. The man not only read all relevant science publications in English, he published in them!

“But the Russian government disavowed their actions,” Special Agent Wilkinson pointed out. “If they don’t want to be tried as criminals - and for capital crimes - they should cooperate.”

“They have family in Russia, da?” Iwan shook his head. “They betray Russia, family suffer.”

“What about your family?” Special Agent Paris asked. “You’ve been cooperating.”

Iwan shrugged. “No family left. No family I care for, at least.”

Sam couldn’t tell if he really didn’t care or was trying to hide something. For all his boisterous manners, which were often quite stereotypical Russian, as Daniel had pointed out to her in private, the man had a good poker face. That wasn’t surprising, of course, since he had grown up in the USSR and had been involved in top-secret research.

“I still can’t believe all of them would take the fall.” Wilkinson shook his head. “There’s always someone who turns.”

“Did you offer bribes?” Iwan asked.

Wilkinson frowned at him. “Offering bribes? That would invalidate their testimony!”

“We can point out that cooperation will get them leniency, but we aren’t authorised to offer actual deals,” Paris added.

Oh. Sam winced. As did Iwan, she noted. “You’re following FBI rules and regulations,” she said.

“Of course,” Wilkinson said.

“This is an Alliance investigation,” Sam pointed out. “You don’t answer to the FBI here but to the Alliance. To Alliance High Command,” she emphasised.

“The legal procedures are the same, at least as far as fundamentals are concerned,” Wilkinson retorted. “You can’t bribe a witness, and we aren’t authorised to offer deals.”

Iwan cocked his head, acting as if he was confused. “Legal procedures? This is military and political matter. Result important.”

“We’re not in Russia!” Wilkinson snapped. “We have a working judicial system! People have rights!”

Sam grimaced. She shouldn’t be handling this - she was a scientist, not a lawyer. Or a politician. But the General and the others were meeting with the Alliance leaders. And while the exact chain of command was a little vague, the General had left her in charge here. “We’re investigating an attack on the Alliance and Stargate Command,” she said. “Our priority is to find out what happened and who is responsible. Whether or not that intel is applicable in a court of law is of secondary importance.”

Wilkinson stared at her as if she had threatened to shoot him in the back. “What?”

“Princesses and Generals not care about procedures,” Iwan said. “They want results for military and politics.”

“You might as well torture the prisoners then!” Wilkinson spat.

“Torture doesn’t work,” Paris cut in.

“It work for Russia.”

“We aren’t Russia!” Wilkinson glared at Iwan.

Combining torture with a truth spell would likely work, Sam knew. As long as the victim still knew truth from lies, the spell would detect any falsehood they knowingly said - and they would say something to stop the torture. But that wasn’t an option. “The Alliance doesn’t torture people,” she said. If Wilkinson had met the Princesses for longer than a brief greeting, he would know that.

“Da. Alliance very good about that.” Iwan grinned.

“But deals and bribes are allowed,” Sam went on. “And Kira can check for lies. Whether or not that would invalidate any testimony is irrelevant.”

“Even if it means a war criminal escapes justice?” Wilkinson retorted. “Over a dozen people died because of this attack!”

Sam was tempted to mention Hordak. And Catra. She didn’t, though. Instead, she said: “Do you think any of our prisoners were the masterminds behind the attack?”

Wilkinson frowned at her. “Sidorov was in charge of the Russian troops. Li commanded the Chinese contingent. We don’t have any records of them contacting their superiors in their home countries.”

Absence of evidence wasn’t evidence of absence, though. “They could have had orders for such a contingency,” Sam pointed out. “But do you really think the soldiers we captured acted independently?”

Wilkinson didn’t answer that, but his expression said enough. “We still have no authorisation to offer any plea deals. Or other deals.”

“You have it now,” Sam told him. “I’ll ask Adora to make it an order. In writing.”

Both special agents seemed surprised at that.

“Alliance way, this is,” Iwan told them. “Princesses are honest like that.”

“They aren’t naive,” Sam added. “But they take their responsibilities as leaders seriously. They won’t sacrifice people under their command to save themselves. Or to follow procedures.”

Judging by the glances Wilkinson and Paris exchanged, they weren’t used to that in the FBI.

To be fair, Sam had not been used to that in the Air Force either. Not until she had started serving at Stargate Command under the General and General Hammond, at least.

She looked at the two agents. “Get them to talk. We need to know who to go after in Russia and China.” She smiled at the way Wilkinson and Paris’s eyes widened at that. “This is a political and military matter. Not a matter of jurisdiction.”

“Da!” Iwan nodded. “Like Iran.”

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 14th, 1999

“So, the Chinese government claims that this was all your doing and that your government has had no knowledge about the contact with the Eudondans or the attack on Alliance personnel?”

Wilkinson sounded rather frustrated. Catra could emphasise.

The Chinese general slowly nodded with a polite smile that was just so slightly smug that Catra wanted to slash the mirror glass separating her from the interrogation room and rip it off his face.

“You’re not fooling anyone,” Wilkinson said, shaking his head. “We know you’re lying.”

“I have told you no lie,” Li retorted.

“True,” Kira said next to Catra.

It didn’t mean anything, though. Li hadn’t actually said anything substantial during the interrogation. Of course, as a member of the Stargate Command Council, Li had been aware of magical truth spells - it wouldn’t have made sense to send sorceresses from Etheria to help guard the Stargate and not inform the people in charge of what they could do.

In hindsight, using truth spells on the people in charge would have made more sense, at least in Catra’s opinion.

Wilkinson looked even more frustrated on hearing Kira’s report through the bud in his ear. “What was the plan, anyway? Take us all hostages?” he snapped.

“Not you. Just the friends of She-Ra,” Li replied.

“True.” Kira sounded as surprised as Catra felt - was Li suddenly breaking his silence?

Wilkinson’s eyes had widened, but he quickly recovered and leaned forward on the table separating him and Li. “Catra, Major Carter, Dr Jackson and his wife?”

“Yes.”

“True,” Kira whispered.

“And you thought this would give you leverage to make demands to the Alliance?” Wilkinson asked.

Li slowly nodded again. “The Supreme Commander of the Alliance values her friends dearly.”

“And yet you tried to murder General O’Neill.”

“That was General Sidorov’s plan.”

“True,” Kira reported.

Wilkinson shook his head again. “You had access to the Stargate. You had the freedom to explore the galaxy. Why would you risk all that?”

Li kept smiling without answering.

“He won’t say anything that can be proven as a lie,” Catra said.

“Earlier, I thought he might, but now…” Kira sighed.

The sorceress had to be tiring; keeping up a spell for so long was exhausting. Catra doubted that Kira would bring it up, though. Not until she was about to collapse. The woman probably felt guilty for missing the entire plot until Sam had come in.

“You knew you wouldn’t escape. Hostages or not,” Wilkinson tried again.

“A small chance is better than no chance at all.” Li sounded as if he was quoting someone.

“Were you planning on letting your superiors ‘convince’ you to release the hostages and surrender?”

Li’s smile didn’t change. The man had a great poker face. On the other hand, his refusal to answer was an answer itself.

And, despite Wilkinson’s frustration, this was enough. At least for Catra. “So, Li’s been planning to take the fall for his leaders. Even though no one’s going to believe the story. And he probably set up Sidorov somehow.” Maybe to make himself look better in comparison. Or to get back at the Russian - Catra didn’t think anyone who had to work with Sidorov liked the man even a little bit. Unfortunately, the Russian general hadn’t said a single word. For all his faults, he could shut up perfectly.

“Yes.” Kira nodded in agreement.

“Do you think that this would have changed anything? No one believes your story!” Wilkinson repeated himself.

Li, once more, didn’t answer.

“What do you think was his plan?” Kira asked.

Catra shrugged. “Trade hostages for concessions, maybe.” That was what they usually did in the files she had read. Though that only worked when the kidnappers had managed to get away in the first place and managed to make a deal later, from a safe position. She couldn’t remember anyone actually successfully using hostages to escape.

“In the movies, they usually demand a flyer for some reason. Maybe he wanted to use the Stargate?” Kira suggested while Wilkinson repeated himself again in the interrogation room and Li predictably failed to answer.

“And get stranded without supplies on some rock? Or end up eaten by a monster? Not that we would have let him go - he knows too much,” Catra replied.

“What do you think would have happened if you had killed us all?” Wilkinson said. “To China.”

That was a good question.

“I do not think Princess She-Ra would punish others for my crimes. Or would let anyone else do this.”

“True.”

“And do you think that extends to your government?”

Once again, Li didn’t answer.

Well, they would find out. Once they reported back to the Alliance High Command with the results of the interrogation.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 14th, 1999

"...and in the face of worldwide outrage at the use of chemical weapons against the Alliance, the Russian and Chinese governments both independently released a statement that their representatives at Stargate Command acted on their own and denied any responsibility for the attack. In other words, either the Russians and Chinese are lying, or they have no control at all over their most important forces! And neither the current Russian president nor his elected successor has been seen in public since the attack, prompting speculation about a coup."

"...meanwhile, the United Nations Secretary-General called upon 'all sides to refrain from hasty actions', and various nations from the Middle East condemned 'unprovoked aggression against sovereign nations for alleged crimes committed by individuals'."

"...while the Secretary General of NATO has released a statement that the organisation is 'closely coordinating with the Alliance' with regard to their response to the attack on the Stargate but refused to comment if Article Five has been brought up so far. With uncertainty whether or not NATO countries in the Alliance have access to space-based weapons, it remains…"

"...in response to the senator's repeated statements that 'another day of infamy' required an 'equally swift and decisive response from the United States', he asked whether or not they consider Newfoundland part of the United States, and what…"

"...the world holds its breath as the Alliance leadership is gathering to decide whether or not they will respond to the Stargate Incident with war."

"...where the peace protesters and the counter-protesters clashed violently, and the police arrested…"

Jack O'Neill sighed and switched the TV off. Yeah, releasing the news about the attack on Stargate Command had gone about as well as he had expected - but they couldn't have let the Russians and Chinese set the narrative or something. As if anyone would believe anything what either country claimed! Well, except for half the world, according to the United Nations.

He got up, checked that he hadn't left anything on his desk that he needed, and walked out of his office, nodding at the additional guards posted in the hallways as he passed them. Security was very tight, with most of the allied countries' leaders present. Two frigates in orbit directly over Brussels, a full regiment of his command ready to drop in combat shuttles, the rest of the special forces on standby… He snorted at the thought that if the Alliance decided to attack Russia and China, they could just change their preplanned deployments and strike at a moment's notice. Or rather, mop up what the frigates above Russia and China would have left standing after Priest opened with orbital bombardment.

Getting into the meeting room took getting scanned - three times. It was a bit of an overreaction, in his opinion, but he hadn't said so out loud.

This time, uniforms and suits had about equal numbers inside the room. Jack nodded at the guards inside the room, then headed to his friends, trying not to catch the attention of the assembled presidents and prime ministers. He wasn't in the mood to make small talk with politicians on a good day, certainly not now when everyone would want to use him to get more information about the Etherians' thoughts on the matter.

Exchanging greetings with his team and the Etherians, he took his seat. "Let's see whether or not we get to do a live-fire invasion exercise in Russia and China."

Catra and Glimmer chuckled, but Adora frowned at him. "Don't give Priest ideas! He already proposed that we have a volunteer 'act on his own and bombard all strategic assets of both countries'."

That would actually be very fitting, in Jack's opinion. Show the Russians and Chinese that if they tried to be clever with 'rogue soldiers acting on their own', they would suffer the same in return. And since it would be a clone acting, they could just have him change his name and claim they had punished him - no one would be able to tell the difference…

"Don't you get any ideas either!" Adora told him.

He gave her his best innocent smile. It didn't work, of course, but Glimmer and Catra laughed again. Then the meeting began, and everyone stopped laughing.

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"...and so while we are almost absolutely certain that the dealing with the Eurondans wasn't an unauthorised action by Generals Sidorov and Li, but a coordinated plot by at least parts of the governments of Russia and China, we don't have sufficient intel to say the same about the actual assassination attempts," Adora finished her report.

"Do we have proof of this?" the German Bundeskanzler asked.

"Not according to your legal standards," Glimmer replied. "But General Li refused to answer any question that could have shed light on that while admitting his own guilt."

"While under the effect of a magic spell," the President pointed out.

"No. Kira cast the spell on herself to detect truth, not on Li," Glimmer corrected him.

Jack had to suppress a snort when the President frowned at her. "It's not going to make a difference for the United Nations. They'll claim you can't trust magic."

"We could have a signed confession, witnesses and a recording of the Russian and Chinese leadership plotting together, and they

would claim we made it up!" Glimmer shot back.

She wasn't wrong, of course.

"Besides, neither the UN nor Russia and China pose any military threat to us," Glimmer added. "They cannot stop us from doing what we want."

"Which, according to our analysts, is what prompted the whole thing in the first place," the French Président pointed out.

"Well, that ship has sailed. They did it, and if we don't respond, they or someone else will try it again," the British Prime Minister said.

"We cannot let such an attack go unpunished," his Canadian counterpart added.

"And we won't," Adora said. "But what will we do? Wipe out the Russian and Chinese military and arrest their leaders?"

"That would throw both countries into chaos!" the Bundeskanzler protested. "Millions of civilians would be endangered from the internal strife alone, and other countries would be encouraged to take action against the disarmed nations!"

"And we don't have the forces or the political capital to occupy Russia or China, let alone both of them," the President added. "We would be dragged into an insurrection at once."

"So, they're holding their people hostage?" Glimmer scoffed. "All the more reason to not let them get away with this!"

"We could take out their strategic weapons," Catra suggested. "And their leaders."

"That would still leave them leaderless and with huge armies that will be dragged into the resulting power struggle. A new civil war in either country would be almost certain," the British Prime Minister said. "If we want to take out the leaders responsible for

the attack, we need to ensure that a replacement government is ready to take over."

One that will be seen as a puppet regime, Jack thought. With all that entails.

The President nodded. "And we'll still have to be on alert against asymmetrical responses like terrorists sponsored by either country."

"We can handle that with our updated scanners!" Entrpata chimed in. "Unless they have more alien technology like that gas they used."

"We need more information," the British Prime Minister said. "We need to know what is happening in the Russian and Chinese governments. If there are internal divisions that we could exploit. And who is responsible for the whole affair, of course," he added almost as an afterthought.

"So we do that. And we need to release the information we have so we can keep up the pressure on Russia and China," the President agreed with a glance at Adora and Glimmer. "And placate our own public."

Both nodded, although a little reluctantly.

"And we need to find those Eurondans and investigate them," Catra added.

Jack nodded. They hadn't found them yet, but with Lenkova cooperating, that was just a question of time. Sooner or later, the aliens would contact their 'partners' again, but this time, the Alliance would meet them - disguised as Russians and Chinese.

More spying. And no crushing the Russians or Chinese. For the moment, at least.

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Spy Games Part 6

Palais des Nations, Geneva, Switzerland, December 15th, 1999

"...and that's why the Russian and Chinese forces have been expelled from Stargate Command," the Canadian ambassador to the United Nations finished his explanation.

"You cannot unilaterally decide that!" the Russian ambassador protested - without being invited to speak, Adora noted.

But the Secretary-General didn't intervene. Well, it was an emergency session.

"It was not a unilateral decision, but the decision of the majority of the Stargate Command Council," the Canadian retorted.

Adora felt a little bad about having the Canadians defend the decision - they were not part of the Stargate Command Council. But the Stargate was on their territory, and they hadn't refused when asked by the Alliance.

"That is not in the purview of the Stargate Command Council!" the Russian snapped. "The Stargate is under the control of the United Nations!"

A lot of people present in the hall seemed to agree with that - Adora saw them nod, and the murmurs grew louder. And the Russian was correct - the United Nations had officially taken control of Earth's Stargate. Which, Adora reminded herself, had been the right decision since they represented Earth and the Stargate belonged to Earth as a whole.

On the other hand, removing the Russian and Chinese troops from Stargate Command was also the right decision. They had betrayed the trust of everyone else and endangered the entire planet. And they had tried to murder Catra and our friends, she reminded herself, clenching her teeth at the thought.

“Russian and Chinese forces have attempted to take control of the Stargate, engaged in secret dealings with an alien civilisation for unknown reasons and attacked Stargate Command with *chemical weapons*!” the Canadian replied. “This is not acceptable!”

“Lies and slander!” the Russian protested. “You have no proof of anything!”

“We have caught the culprits in the act!”

The Russian sneered. “You have captured our troops and refused to let our government talk to them - and refused to have the affair investigated by an independent commission! Your claims are baseless - mere lies made up to cover your blatant attempt to control the Stargate for your war!”

Adora managed not to wince at the loud agreement from half - or more - the ambassadors present that filled the hall.

The Canadian ambassador glared at his counterpart. “Your attempts to play the victim won’t work. We have proof of your attempts to control the base’s system and your attack!”

“Fabrications of your own!” The Russian scoffed, and more ambassadors cheered.

Adora clenched her teeth again. Glimmer had been right - the truth didn’t matter. The rulers of those countries ignored the proof presented to them.

But they couldn’t ignore reality, either.

The Canadian shook his head, but before he could go on, the Chinese ambassador spoke up - unprompted as the Russian one, which, Adora understood, was very unusual for him. “You do not have the right to take control of the Stargate,” he said. “That would require a decision by the United Nations Security Council.”

Which the Russians and Chinese would veto, of course.

Adora knew she should be waiting to be given permission to speak, but it seemed no one was following the rules anyway, so she stood up. She was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, so this fell to her. "The Stargate is of vital importance for the Alliance's war against the Goa'uld. We cannot allow untrustworthy powers control over it - and we certainly cannot allow hostile forces control over it. Russian and Chinese forces have tried to take control of the Stargate and attacked Alliance forces, killing several of our soldiers. They also have made contact with unknown alien forces and used their weapons against us. Russia and China may claim that those were the actions of rogue forces, but even if that were true, it means that both countries sent untrustworthy, hostile forces to Stargate Command. In any case, we cannot and will not allow your forces to remain part of Stargate Command and threaten our forces and the war."

"You cannot do that!" the Russian ambassador yelled.

"We can," Glimmer hissed next to Adora.

"This is a military decision taken by Alliance command," Adora went on, ignoring the man. "The trustworthy elements of Stargate Command remain in control of it, fulfilling the United Nations mandate. It is up to the United Nations Security Council to decide if they wish to add more forces to Stargate Command."

No one had to say out loud that any decision that didn't please the Alliance would be vetoed.

"That's a blatant attempt to conquer Earth!" the Iranian ambassador spat.

Adora sat down as others chimed in despite the Secretary-General's attempts to restore order.

"The Stargate belongs to Earth - you said so yourself!"

"So much for the honour of the aliens!"

"You brought that on yourself!"

“Don’t play the victim!”

“Infidels!”

“We won’t let you attack us with impunity and then claim it was a rogue soldier!”

“Colonialists! We won’t let you take away our sovereignty!”

“Shame on you!”

“Shame on you!”

“Well, we know where everyone stands,” Glimmer commented to her.

Adora nodded. Not that it changed anything. Technically, the Stargate was still under nominal UN control. And the United Nations could move to add more countries to the Command Council - like India. But Adora was sure that every country picked would be vetoed by either Russia and China or the United States, France and Britain.

Of course, that also depended on what exactly had been going on with the Russian and Chinese governments.

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 15th, 1999

“Just for record: I would like to ask for asylum. Before being deported back to mother Russia with others.”

Samantha Carter looked up from her laptop’s screen and at Iwan. “You won’t be deported.”

He shrugged with a grin. “Never know. Bureaucracy can make mistake. Even Western bureaucracy, as I found out here. And Russia demanded all people here back.”

They also protested against the removal of the Russian contingent at Stargate Command, but that was just performative - Sam doubted that even the Russians actually expected the Alliance to leave Russians near the Stargate. They would all go, except, possibly, Lenkova and Iwan, and that only because Adora and the other princesses had made it clear that sending either into 'protective custody' far away from Newfoundland wasn't going to happen.

Sam agreed with that stance. Both Iwan and Lenkova had made it clear where they stood in the conflict between Russia and the Alliance. The odds of either being a spy for Russia were too low to be taken seriously. Of course, a small voice in the back of her mind whispered, either could be working for a faction of Russia's rulers that wasn't currently in power. Lenkova had been trained by an intel agency, and Iwan would have had to pass a lot of loyalty tests to be allowed to work with top-secret alien technology…

She pushed the voice away. She wasn't going to become paranoid. And both would be closely observed by people watching out for spies, anyway. People like Wilkinson.

The FBI agent in question looked up from his own - far less advanced - computer. "No one's getting deported until we've finished our investigation. We still haven't found out what everyone involved knew."

"And we probably won't," Agent Paris added. "Most of them aren't talking. And those who do talk are only admitting the bare minimum."

"That's still confirmation for some claims," Wilkinson retorted. "And we have other sources for information to correlate their claims."

Paris raised her eyebrows. "That only works when people talk."

Wilkinson pouted in return. "They'll start talking when they realise that that's the only way they'll get out of a cell."

“Oh, compared to welcome back in Russia, Alliance cell is paradise. Or luxury hotel, at least.” Iwan grinned. “Siberia is very cold this time of year. And grave is colder.”

Sam glanced at Lenkova. Unlike everyone else in the room, the Lieutenant wasn’t working on anything. She was just staring at the TV in the corner. With the volume set as low as it was, Sam doubted that Lenkova was hearing anything.

Then again, it wasn’t as if there was any news on the TV - it was just loops of things they already knew, with banners at the bottom adding more ‘breaking news’ that was anything but breaking.

“They haven’t talked even when offered asylum,” Wilkinson said with a scowl.

“KGB picked spies well, much experience,” Iwan said.

Lenkova tensed, Sam saw. “Some will talk, eventually,” the Lieutenant said after a moment - without looking at anyone in the room. “Once they realise that they can get a good deal from the Alliance.”

“Wouldn’t they know that already?” Paris asked. “They’ve been working with us for months.”

“They take long time to trust, if ever,” Iwan said. “West was enemy for decades, so no trust there. And Alliance - Princesses - look too good to be true.”

And the Russians and Chinese at Stargate Command hadn’t worked with the Alliance except for selected individuals like Kira. “What about the Chinese?” Sam asked after checking that her computer was still working on her analysis.

“Same as Russians, just more secret,” Iwan said with a shrug.

“I wouldn’t say this. They’ve been more cooperative,” Wilkinson said.

"Marginally," Paris disagreed. "And that could be misinformation."

"We can check their claims." Wilkinson looked at Lenkova. "Once we can contact the Eurondans."

"I've given you all the addresses that I remembered," Lenkova told him. She hadn't looked at the man - or Sam had missed it.

"And we're analysing the data," Iwan said. "But all are empty planets so far."

"The Eurondans should contact us soon." Lenkova turned around. "They seemed very eager to make a trade deal when I saw them. But I didn't have much direct contact."

Eager - or desperate. Lenkova had mentioned that the Eurondans were fighting a war, though they hadn't revealed against whom. Nevertheless, they were potential allies. But with the Russians and Chinese banned from the Stargate, the Alliance would have some explaining to do to gain the Eurondans' trust.

Her computer beeped. Had it finished the analysis already? That would… No. It was a message from the spy bots they had placed around the Stargates used to contact the Eurondans. Oh.

"We've received a message from the Eurondans," she told the others present while she forwarded the message to the General, Adora and the rest of Alliance Command. "They've sent the address for the next meeting."

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 16th, 1999

"Finally, progress!" Catra grinned as she approached the Stargate. "No more waiting!"

"We've had diplomatic meetings around the clock," Bow said as he joined her in the ready area. "Adora and Glimmer are still in one. I

wouldn’t call that waiting.”

She shrugged in return. “Might as well be. We need intel, and we won’t get it talking to people who know less than we do.” Such as the rest of the Alliance leaders.

“Other countries have more sources than the Alliance has, at least in Russia and China,” Bow pointed out.

“That doesn’t mean their sources are worth any damn,” Catra retorted. “None of them had any clue about the Stargate plot, had they?” She cocked her head and flashed her teeth.

“Well, the British sources are mostly focused on that recently surrendered city,” Bow said. “Hong Kong.”

Probably planning to take it back, Catra thought. With just a single corvette in orbit, the British could take out the entire Chinese military, though it would take a while. And they had already two operational and launched the third and fourth. There were news reports of protests against the Chinese rulers in the streets as well. “I don’t think those sources will tell us who is responsible for the attack on us,” she said. “And I don’t think the Americans are any better off.” It seemed no one had any real idea what was going on amongst the Chinese rulers.

She eyed the Stargate. Sam and Entrapta had assured them that the computers were now clean and safe, and Catra trusted them, but… she still felt a bit uneasy about the trip. Not that she would show it, of course. But knowing that the Russians and Chinese had infiltrated the entire base so thoroughly that they had been able to fool everyone wasn’t a comforting thought at all.

“We don’t know anything about the Eurondans either,” Bow went on. “Well, nothing except that they are humans - or look human - and want supplies in exchange for technology because they are fighting a war.”

Catra nodded. “Heavy water, food, and other raw materials.” That meant that they still had the production capacity to use the

resources, so they weren't reduced to fighting a guerilla war with whatever supplies they could scrounge up. But it also meant that they had lost whatever access to resources they had before, so their situation wasn't sustainable.

"But we don't know who they are fighting. They apparently never told Lenkova." Bow glanced at the Russian - or was that ex-Russian? - standing a bit to the side.

She was also staring at the gate. As the only one who had met the Eurondans before who wasn't currently in a cell, she had to come with them, but it didn't seem as if she was looking forward to the trip. Probably still feeling guilty about ratting out the Russian plans. If she had heard them - they were close enough for it, but the gate room was noisy as usual - she didn't show it.

Whatever. "Can't be the snakes," Catra said. "They would have bombed the planet already." And if the Eurondans had spaceships, they could get those resources themselves.

"They could have the technology to hold them off," Bow objected. "They do have energy shields."

That was a possibility. On the other hand… "They didn't mention the Goa'uld, as far as we know," Catra said. "They would have if they were fighting them, if only to check that Earth hadn't any dealings with them. Or to warn us."

Bow nodded in agreement.

Catra was about to comment further when her ears twitched - she knew that voice! "Adora's coming!"

"Yes, she… Oh." Bow blushed a little. "You mean she's arrived."

"Yes!" Catra was already moving towards the main door. "Hey, Adora!" she called out as soon as it opened.

"Catra!" her love beamed at her, and they embraced. And kissed.

Glimmer and Bow greeted each with more restraint, not that Catra cared. They hadn't been separated for days because of a stupid plot by stupid people.

"So, done with the meeting?" Bow tried to make conversation.

Glimmer rolled her eyes, Catra saw as she released Adora. "It's a damn mess with China. The British are 'concerned' about the Hong Kong protests and a possible massacre of the protestors by the Chinese army, and the Americans are worrying about the Taiwanese pushing for independence - or taking over China. They don't seem to be able to settle on either. And we didn't even get to meet the exiled ruler of Tibet."

"Oh?" Catra cocked her head.

Adora sighed. "It's a mess."

"China has a lot of problems that were only kept in check thanks to their military," Jack added as he joined them. "Internal and external. Now that their army has been rendered irrelevant, those problems are growing more urgent."

"Their military was obsolete the moment we arrived," Catra pointed out.

"Yes, was." Jack smiled toothily. "But it wasn't that obvious, that blatant, until we kicked them out of here. China could still claim they were a big boy in politics, powerful enough to get access to the Stargate with us. Same as Russia."

Catra nodded. And now that they had lost both the access and the image of power that went with it, everyone who had been holding back out of fear was… no longer holding back.

"If they lose Tibet and Hong Kong, that's going to have consequences for their government. And if Taiwan declares independence - or starts trying to influence mainland China's politics - and the protest movement from ten years ago starts up again, all bets are off."

Jack didn't seem to be too unhappy about that, Catra noted.

"Whatever!" Glimmer said. "I am sick of hearing about China or Russia. We have a meeting with the Eurondans to make!"

"Right." China and Russia could wait.

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Gate Area, PX-812, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill stepped through the wormhole, checked for threats - nothing came up - and took a deep breath. The air smelt just slightly alien but in a familiar way. Oh, he had missed that feeling, that smell, of exploration. Of course, if he commented on that, Carter would claim it was just his imagination since her drone's sensors had not detected anything alien in the air. And she had been rather thorough - after the poison attack by the Chinese, Entrapta and Carter had adjusted their scanner.

But feeling nostalgic for the days when he had been a mere Colonel, going on missions with SG-1, wasn't why they were here. "So, let's check the receiver!" he said.

"Yes, sir." Carter moved to kneel down next to the plain box on the ground at the side of the ramp.

"You left it out in the open like that?" he asked, looking at Lenkova.

"Yes, General. The odds of anyone stumbling over it this gate were considered too low to bother," she replied with a slight frown.

Whether that was aimed at her former superior, who ordered it, or at herself for following the order, Jack couldn't tell. "Well, the Eurondans stumbled on the address here, as did we."

"Yes, General." She grinned briefly.

It was annoyance at her superior, then, Jack decided.

“Perimeter secure,” Isa reported.

“Orbital scan clean,” Entrapta added from where she was sitting on Emily. The big bot’s upper body was rotating back and forth as it kept scanning the sky, but that didn’t seem to bother Entrapta.

Catra and Bow were looking at the grass around them - and on the ramp. “It doesn’t look like anyone travelled here since the Russians’ last visit we know about,” Bow said.

“Or they cleaned up after them,” Catra added.

Bow nodded in agreement.

Jack saw Carter stand up next to the box. “There is no new message, and the receiver’s memory shows no sign of tampering, sir.”

That meant that the meeting with the Eurondans was still on.

Jack looked around. PX-812 was deserted. Both literally and figuratively, as Daniel said; the Stargate was in the middle of a sandy steppe, not quite a desert but getting there. “Did you find anything here?” he asked Lenkova.

“No, General. The native flora and fauna is rather primitive. No sign of civilisation.”

Jack nodded. That had been in her briefing. “Some planets are a bust like that. Can’t always hit the interesting ones.”

“There were plans to settle it,” she added. “But the lack of large sources of fresh water, especially near the Stargate, made that proposal uneconomical.”

“You could drop ice asteroids on the planet,” Entrapta chimed in, walking over to them on her hair. “That wouldn’t be enough for an ocean, of course, but you could make a great lake. That would

sustain a kingdom or two. Maybe three if you use genetically adjusted plants that don't need as much water. Perfuma created some for the former Fright Zone."

"We don't have spaceships in the system," Carter reminded her.

Entrapta nodded. "Oh, right. And it's a bit far for a trip. But still faster than setting up a factory here and building a spaceship to get ice asteroids, I think."

Neither Russia nor China had the technology to build spaceships on Earth, so they wouldn't have been able to build them here either, Jack knew - checking the space programs of the two countries had been the Alliance's first priority back home - but the Alliance could do either. And he didn't doubt that a number of people were already planning to build such projects for after the war.

"Speaking of water," Daniel spoke up. "The Eurondans want heavy water, you said?"

"Yes," Lenkova replied.

"I wonder why they don't set up a production facility off-world," Daniel went on. "This planet is not suitable for that, but there are others."

The Alliance Council had gone over that before the mission. They didn't have enough data to draw conclusions. They could speculate, though.

"They might not know a suitable planet," Carter said.

"Or they lack the resources for such a project," Catra added. "It might take everything they have to stop their enemy from winning the war."

That would make the Eurondans desperate. Something the Russians and Chinese would have exploited or planned to exploit.

The Etherians wouldn't do that, of course. And that might help earn the aliens' trust.

Though, in Jack's experience, people who were waging a bloody, lengthy war tended to be a lot more distrustful, even paranoid, than people who were at peace. Of course, as Daniel would say, they couldn't judge other cultures according to their own experiences and biases.

Well, they would see. It was almost the agreed - or announced - time for the meeting.

As if the Stargate had read his mind, the Wormhole started forming.

"Showtime," Jack said, grinning. "Be on your best behaviour - we don't want to spook them!"

He heard several snorts while the wormhole stabilised. Then, everyone grew serious as the first figure stepped through the gate.

*****

Adora looked at the man who had appeared on the ramp. He was tall - well, taller than her, about the same height as Jack - and wearing a dark green-brownish uniform. And he was armed with one of those Eurondan energy guns - his hand went to its grip as soon as he saw Adora and her friends standing at the bottom of the ramp.

"Tralan." Svetlana took a step forward, nodding at him.

"Lieutenant Lenkova." He didn't draw his weapon. But he was very tense, Adora could tell. Especially when he glanced at her - no, at Catra. And at Emily and Isa. "I expected other people."

That was her cue. Adora smiled widely at him and walked a few steps towards the ramp, past Svetlana. "Hello. I am Adora - She-Ra, Princess of Power. I am the Supreme Commander of the

Alliance against the Goa'uld." She gestured at her friends. "This is Queen Glimmer of Brightmoon, Princess Entrapta of Dryl, General Jack O'Neill, Major Samantha Carter, Tech-master Bow, Dr Daniel Jackson, Sha're, Catra and Teal'c. You already know Svetlana."

"I am Tralan. I represent the Eurondans." He glanced at Svetlana, then back at Adora. "We expected to meet our kindred from Russia and the Chinese."

Adora let her smile slip a little. "We know. But those Russians and Chinese officers who made a deal with you were disavowed by their countries and declared rogues." Which they had, even if Adora didn't believe their claims.

"What?"

"Yes. According to the Russian and Chinese leaders, Generals Sidorov and Li acted on their own, and for their own profit, not for their countries." That was all technically true, Adora knew, but she still felt like a liar presenting it like this.

"They… deceived us? They promised to trade us dearly needed supplies in exchange…" Tralan grew even tenser. No one else had joined him so far - according to Svetlana, the Eurondans usually had a larger group but only followed through once their advance party gave them the go-ahead.

"Apparently, they deceived everyone, including their own soldiers like the Lieutenant here." Jack nodded at Svetlana. "They tried to kill us as well when it came out, but that didn't work out for them."

"I see."

Adora gave him her best smile. "But we heard you were fighting a war and in need of help, so we came to see what we could do for you."

"Without exorting your technology from you," Glimmer added.

“Yes!” Entrapta chimed in, beaming at Tralan. “But if you want to share, we won’t turn you down! You’ve got some nice technology - we got some samples from those who attacked us - and the data compression you managed is impressive. And that poison was quite advanced as well.”

“Ah…” Tralan smiled weakly and looked a bit confused. But that was normal when people met Entrapta for the first time.

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded. “So, we’d like to meet your leaders to discuss this. We don’t know what enemy you’re fighting or your circumstances, so we don’t know how we can best help you.”

“I see. I have to inform our leader about this. You have told us a lot, and he must decide how to proceed.” Tralan slowly said.

“At least they don’t have to vote on it,” Adora heard Glimmer mutter.

“We’ll be here all day if you need additional information,” Jack said. “Seeing the sights, admiring the view…” He turned his head to look at the sandy dunes around them.

“Jack!” Daniel hissed through clenched teeth.

“Good.” Tralan nodded, then pulled out a communicator and whispered into it.

“He’s telling them something came up, and he needs to return,” Catra said in a low voice.

The wormhole collapsed, and Tralan walked over to the D.H.D. to dial the home address. The wormhole formed soon afterwards. “I’ll be back,” he said before stepping through.

“Do you think that’s their home address? Or a temporary base?” Entrapta asked once the wormhole had collapsed again.

“It is the same address they used in our last meeting,” Svetlana said.

“It would be smart of them to route travel through a temporary base on another planet rather than risk revealing their home address,” Glimmer said.

Adora nodded in agreement.

“But not everyone always does the smart thing,” Catra pointed out.

“See: Russia and China,” Jack added. “But we shouldn’t assume that this is their home address.”

“Well, if we are to help them, we’ll have to visit their home world,” Catra said. “Can’t just act without decent intel.”

They could hand over supplies, of course, Adora knew. But they could help much better if they knew more. And it was always best to visit the people you were dealing with. Well, often, at least. “In any case, this went pretty well, I think,” she said.

“We’ll see,” Jack retorted. “He wasn’t happy to see us.”

“He was very surprised by the presence of Catra and Isa,” Daniel said. “It didn’t seem as if he had met aliens before.”

“He also looked at Emily a lot,” Bow added. “But that might just be because he wanted to guess how advanced our technology was.”

Adora nodded. That sounded like a good guess.

“He also glanced at me, although covertly,” Teal’c commented.

Daniel frowned. “Really? He might have encountered Jaffa before. Or he recognised the symbol of Apophis.”

“Well, if they are fighting the Goa’uld, it shouldn’t be hard to earn their trust,” Glimmer said. “We just have to defeat the Goa’uld attacking them.”

While Adora nodded, she couldn't help feeling that it wouldn't be so easy. "Let's build a camp," she said. Just in case.

*****

Samantha Carter was halfway through a data analysis for a side project when the Stargate activated again. She quickly closed her laptop and got up while Emily placed herself in the middle of the group. Just in case the Eurondans overreacted - they didn't know what the Russians and Chinese had told them about the Alliance. If they attacked through the Stargate, trying to take them hostage…

But when the wormhole stabilised, Tralan stepped through, followed by an older man, a younger woman and several younger men. Probably guards, Sam thought - they stayed back and kept an eye on both the Alliance delegation as well as their surroundings. All Eurondans were wearing the same uniforms, though that wouldn't be unusual for a people at war.

"Greetings," the older man said, smiling as he stepped off the ramp. "I am Alar, the leader of my people. This is Farrell, my second-in-command. You already know Tralan." He didn't introduce the other Eurondans, so Sam had been right - they were guards.

Adora returned the smile and introduced herself and everyone else.

Alar nodded at everyone, then looked at the camp they had erected. "Are you taking possession of the planet?"

"What? No!" Adora blushed. "That's just a temporary camp," she said.

"We didn't want to build an actual base," Entrapta chimed in. "Or we would have built walls and underground shelters. But we had this new design to test, so… An actual meeting room is better than just standing in the open, right?" She beamed at Alar.

‘Room’ was a bit optimistic. It was meant for temporary bases on safe planets and was more like a tent, just with sturdier walls and roof. It wasn’t an actual prefab building, much less a shelter, though they had Emily’s shield for protection. All in all, it was, in Sam’s opinion, far less impressive than what the Alliance could build and had built for meetings. But it would serve well enough and hopefully not make them appear belligerent.

“Indeed.” Alar briefly chuckled. “We’ve been reduced to staying in our underground defence facility for years, so we’re not used to staying in the open any more.” He looked at the sky. “Though it is comforting to see a sky above us where we don’t have to fear bombers attacking us.”

It sounded as if they were in a desperate situation, Sam noted. Alar might be exaggerating their plight, though that would weaken his position in potential negotiations. Unless the Russians and Chinese had let him know how the Etherians felt about helping people in need. Then again, if they had, and if the Eurondans had believed them, wouldn’t they have tried to contact the Alliance?

The General would say that I’m starting to think like a spook, Sam thought with a slightly rueful smile as they entered the meeting room.

Farrell’s eyes seemed to linger not only on Catra and Isa but also on Teal’c. Like Tralan before. If Teal’c hadn’t mentioned it, she might not have noticed that. Oh - Farrell seemed to glance at Bow and Sha’re as well. That seemed a little weird.

“Please take a seat!” Adora gestured at the row of chairs lined up on one side of the table in the middle of the room.

“Thank you.” Alar smiled at her and took a seat. Farrell and Tralan followed, flanking him, and the guards took up positions at the back.

Adora cleared her throat. “So… We’ve heard you’ve been looking for help because you’re fighting a war you’re losing.”

Alar nodded. “Yes. A war against an enemy that already controls the majority of our landmass and has driven us underground with constant bombing attacks. For decades, we have been holding our own thanks to our superior technology, protected by our defence field, but we lost access to the resources we need to keep defending ourselves. Sooner or later, we will be at the mercy of our foes.”

That was a very frank opening, Sam noted. And it was pretty much a perfect pitch for the Etherians. For some of them, at least, she amended her thought - Adora, Bow and Entrapta seemed very empathic. Glimmer and Catra, less so.

“Who are you fighting?” Glimmer asked.

Alar winced. “Another nation. We’ve coexisted with them for centuries, but they kept expanding, breeding indiscriminately. They showed no respect for our culture, our values, our way of life. War became inevitable.”

“We call them ‘Breeders’,” Farrell added.

“That’s not what they call themselves, I assume,” Daniel spoke up.

Alar winced again. “They call themselves the ‘Alliance’.”

“Oh.” Adora grimaced - as did Glimmer. “That’s…”

“...an unfortunate coincidence, as I understand,” Alar said with a slight smile. “But when the Russians and Chinese told us about an Alliance taking control over the majority of their world, it sounded familiar - and concerning - to us.”

Yes, Sam could understand that. And the Russians and the Chinese would have played that coincidence up.

“And what do you call yourselves?” Daniel asked.

“We’re the Eurondan Nation,” Alar said. “Though it sounds much grander than it is, now that we have been reduced to sheltering in our underground facility and fending off the attacks of the enemy with our aero-fighters.”

“I am the first to say that airpower is key to victory on the battlefield,” the General said. “But air power alone generally isn’t enough to control significant territory. You need boots on the ground for that.”

Farrell shook her head. “The surface of our world has been poisoned since the start of the war. It is so hostile, ground forces cannot operate effectively there and survive - the enemy found that out early on.”

Sam drew a sharp breath. The surface of their world was poisoned to that degree? That was horrible.

“How do you survive?” Adora asked with a gasp.

“By rationing our resources and living on hydroponically grown yeast,” Farrell replied.

Adora shook her head. “We can change that. We can heal your world.”

“Perfuma can create plants that filter out the poison from the soil and the air,” Entrapta said. “She did so for the Fright Zone.”

Adora nodded. She was probably pondering using a boost from returning the magic to clean up the planet.

“And we should be able to ship in food,” Bow added.

“But first, we’ll have to end your war,” Glimmer said.

“If you are as powerful as we’ve heard - and as you claim - then the enemy won’t be able to stand against you,” Alar said. “Please, save us. Please, help us destroy them.”

“Destroy them?” Glimmer shook her head. “It sounds like you’ve already almost destroyed each other and your world.”

Sam agreed with that assessment. It sounded like an apocalyptic war.

“We had no choice but to fight if we wanted to survive,” Alar said. “The enemy is ruthless. If you leave them be, they’ll attack us again as soon as they can.”

Sam felt forced to agree. If they had fought for decades, wrecking their world, then it was unlikely that they could make a lasting peace.

Adora and the other Etherians, however, clearly disagreed. Sam could tell.

“We’ll make them see reason,” Glimmer said.

Alar didn’t seem convinced. “All we need are supplies. Even just deuterium oxide to fuel our reactors will be enough to save us,” he said. “Everything else, we can source or substitute.”

“And then you can defeat your enemy?” the General asked.

“Yes.”

“Then why did you lose access to this resource in the first place if having access will be enough to win?” The General tilted his head to the side and spread his hands.

“An unfortunate combination of underestimating the enemy and overestimating our own forces,” Alar said with a frown. “A mistake which won’t be repeated.”

“Because you’ll be making new mistakes?” Catra cut in with a snort. “You can’t assume everything will go as planned.”

“The enemy gets a vote too. That’s why he’s the enemy,” Bow added. “Or so the saying goes.”

Sam glanced at the General - he had snorted at that - but he didn't comment any further.

Alar's frown deepened for a moment before he focused on Adora. "All we need are supplies. We can handle our war and do not wish to distract and divert you from your own struggle."

"We can handle the distraction," Glimmer said, a bit flippantly in Sam's opinion.

"And if it serves to end a war and save lives, then it's the right thing to do." Adora nodded and smiled confidently at the Eurondans. "Trust us, we can do it."

"Can you?" Farrell asked. "In order to operate on our world, you would have to use the Stargate to deploy and supply your forces. As we understand it, that would be a significant effort even for your Alliance and hinder you from using the Stargate for much of anything else."

That was true. Sam had run the numbers - any large-scale deployment through a Stargate would require a massive effort to sustain it long-term.

"We don't need to deploy forces through the Stargate. We can send a task force with frigates," Adora retorted. "But we don't need to deploy an army right now. All we need is to talk to your enemy."

Daniel nodded. "A neutral mediator might be all you need to end this war."

They were too optimistic, in Sam's opinion. A bitter war over decades generally couldn't be solved with some mediation. But that didn't mean you shouldn't try. And they needed more data. All they knew about this war was what the Eurondans had told them so far. They didn't even know where Euronda was located or its gate address.

“It would be futile. The enemy cannot be reasoned with. We tried that, to avoid the war, but they would not listen to us.” Alar shook his head. “Please. All we need to save our people is fuel for our reactors. You do not need to concern yourselves with our conflict any further. And in exchange, we can offer you our technology. Which is, as I understand, in parts even superior to your advanced technology.” He smiled at Adora. “We do not wish to drag you into our war to fight our enemy. We merely wish to trade fairly.”

Adora glanced at Glimmer and the General before turning back to Alar. “But we could end the war and help you restore your planet. Save lives! Surely that would be better than just letting you fight on.”

“And you wouldn’t have to risk underestimating your enemy again,” the General said.

“It is a risk we are willing to take,” Alar retorted. “It is our world. Our duty.”

“And what if we won’t help you without at least trying to make peace first?” Glimmer asked.

Alar openly scowled at that. “It seems that the Russians and Chinese told us the truth - you attempt to take control of our world and enforce your own rules on us.”

“What? No!” Adora blurted out. Then she blinked. “Not like that, not really. But you can’t expect us just to send you supplies for your war!”

“And what about your people?” Glimmer asked. “We offer you peace and a restored world. Why would you want your people to suffer, hiding underground, if they could return to the surface to live in peace?”

“Most of our people aren’t suffering,” Alar shot back. “They’re in stasis, awaiting the end of the war.”

Adora gasped. “You’ve put your people in stasis?”

Sam stared at him.

“Oh! To save on resources? That seems quite a clever solution!” Entrapta nodded. “As long as you don’t need more resources to keep them in stasis than supplying them while awake would be, of course. Or if you start running out of resources to keep them in stasis, which I guess is the problem if you are running out of fuel for your reactors. Unless you don’t need power for this? And people in stasis cannot help you in your war effort. Though if you’re already forced into an underground bunker, I guess that’s not an option any more because you lack the production capacity to use the additional manpower.”

Sam winced. Entrapta was correct, but the way she said it…

Alar pressed his lips together.

“Do you really want to risk losing the war?” Daniel asked, leaning forward.

“You do not understand,” Alar replied. “The Breeders cannot be reasoned with. They will not change their ways.”

“Then help us understand!” Adora snapped. “We want to help you, but we won’t, can’t, just send you fuel.”

“Why not? All we ask for is a fair trade,” Alar shook his head. “We had a deal with the Russians and Chinese, or so we thought. Will you keep us from looking for other countries on your planet willing to trade with us?”

That was a delicate problem. The Alliance could block such trade deals, but they were supposed to do so only to keep Earth and the Alliance safe. Of course, after the attack by the Russians and the Chinese on Stargate Command, that wasn’t as much of a hurdle as it could have been.

“We won’t block you from finding trade partners - provided you won’t endanger Earth and the Alliance,” Glimmer said. “But your

technology was used against us once already. Without further information, we can't let you do that."

"Please," Adora said. "We want to help you. Just let us help you."

"Think of your people," Glimmer added.

Alar scowled again but slowly nodded. Farrell drew a sharp breath but, after exchanging a glance with Alar, pressed her lips together and didn't say anything.

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Spy Games Part 7

Gate Area, PX-812, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra narrowed her eyes. For someone who had something to hide - and she was sure that the Eurondans had something to hide, even if she didn't know yet what it was - Alar had given in a bit too easily. Was he so desperate for supplies? Or was he confident he could keep them from discovering his secret? Or was he trying to betray them like the Russians and Chinese had done? He had been in contact and about to make a deal with them, after all, and they had been his only sources of information about Earth and the Alliance. Who knew what they had told him?

But Adora was smiling at him. "Thank you! We can help you - we can restore your planet's surface once we know what's wrong with it, trust us!"

"Yes!" Entrapta chimed in. "If plants that filter the poison out of the soil and air won't work - or take too long for you - Adora should be able to use her magic to remove the poison. At the very least, a combination of her power and magitech should achieve that result, I think. Although… You said you would restore the surface once the war was over, so you probably have made plans to deal with the poison already, right?"

Alar blinked, then nodded. "We have some plans, yes. In the worst case, we'll wait it out. Once we are safe from our enemies, we have all the time and resources we need to deal with this."

Entrapta gasped. "You want to wait it out? But you said that it lasted for decades already! Oh, wait - is it close to breaking down naturally?"

"It will take a long time to break down, but with our stasis technology, we have the time to wait until we can reclaim the surface and live in safety and peace again," Alar replied. "It is but

a small sacrifice compared to what others have already made for the war."

"But you won't have to make this sacrifice," Adora told him. "Trust us, we can help you. But first, we need to end the war."

"Well, offering to restore the planet's surface should be a great incentive for your enemies - the Eurondan Alliance - to agree to end the war," Glimmer said.

Alar frowned at that. "I doubt that they will agree to make peace. And if they do, I doubt that it will last. Until the Breeders change their ways, they will always threaten us."

"People can change!" Adora said, shaking her head. "We know that - we have fought against the Horde for decades, and then we made peace, and now we are allies!"

Catra winced. Peace on Etheria hadn't come until the Horde had changed - well, dissolved would be a better word - once Horde Prime had arrived. And at that point, they had already been pretty much defeated militarily. Of course, if Horde Prime hadn't arrived, the Horde could have fought on with the forces left even after the core of the Fright Zone had been taken by the Alliance, but they would have lost the initiative and the core of their logistics, so the odds wouldn't have been great… She shook her head. Somehow, she doubted that the Eurondans would settle things like the Princess Alliance had.

"But with the Stargate, you can expand to other worlds," Daniel said. "You do not need to compete for your world - not when many uninhabited worlds are left to be settled!"

"We haven't found a world with the resources we need so far," Farrell said. "And we tried all the addresses we found with the gate."

"And we won't abandon our home. Eurondan is our world; We've been fighting for it for decades. To leave would betray all the sacrifices of our people," Alar added.

“You don’t have to leave,” Daniel retorted. “But you won’t need to compete for resources any more.”

“We can find a world for you that’s not inhabited,” Adora said.

Catra suppressed a snort. That was easier said than done, in her opinion. If they found such a world, without any native civilisation on it, then Earth would also want it.

“Though if you manage to survive underground, then you shouldn’t have any trouble once the surface is habitable again,” Entrapta said. “Especially if we give you a few plants optimised by Perfuma for your planet. Or improved hydroponic cultures - I am sure we can come up with one that makes tiny food!”

Catra snickered at the expression on the Eurondans’ faces. Getting used to Entrapta took a bit.

Adora cleared her throat. “Anyway, let’s focus on ending the war and restoring your world!”

“Yes,” Alar said with a smile that looked as honest as the Russian ambassador’s, in Catra’s opinion.

“Good. So, let’s visit your planet now?” Jack said.

Catra’s ears twitched as she heard Daniel whisper: “Jack! That’s not how you make what is a state visit!”

“But it is a good way to prevent a trap,” Jack whispered back while smiling toothily at the Eurodans.

Catra agreed; it would make it harder for the Eurondans to lay a trap, at least. Sure, they might scrounge up an attack once they were on their planet, but that could be dealt with. Especially if the Eurondans had no idea what Adora could really do.

Although they hadn’t reacted to Entrapta mentioning Adora’s magic, she remembered. That wasn’t a good sign.

Glimmer, though, smiled. “Yes. Unless you wish to prepare for a bigger visit - we could take a ship to your planet in that case.”

“But we…” Entrpata, probably about to say they didn’t have Euronda’s coordinates, was interrupted by Sam whispering to her.

“That won’t be necessary,” Alar said. “You are welcome to visit now. Although, as you would expect, we cannot offer much in the way of hospitality due to the demands of the war.”

“That’s not a problem. We can bring our own food,” Jack replied.

“Jack!”

“General!”

Catra snickered.

*****

Gate Room, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

“Seen one underground bunker, seen them all,” Jack O’Neill muttered as he stepped down the ramp in - presumably - the gate room of the Eurondans. The Eurondan Nation, he corrected himself. This was just one country on a planet.

“I’m not quite sure that’s correct,” Daniel objected on Jack’s left side. “There are stark differences between the architectural styles of different cultures, even when it comes to utilitarian buildings such as bunkers. And when it comes to the gate area, we’re literally talking about the face a world presents to its visitors.”

Jack tilted his head sideways, then made a point of looking around. The room was neither large nor well-lit and lacked any decorations. In fact, it looked pretty new. Then again, Alar had said they had recently discovered the Stargate when expanding their bunker.

“We relocated the Stargate to this room after contact with the Russians and Chinese,” Farrell said. “They impressed upon us that the gate presented a security risk and should be housed accordingly.”

“That explains the guards,” Jack said, nodding at the squad of Eurondans forming a half circle at the back. They looked pretty interchangeable, Jack noted. Alert, but their attention seemed split between their leader and Jack’s group. Not much experience handling ground combat then - not unlike an airman fresh out of basic. Jack almost snorted at the comparison when he realised that the Eurondans were like an Air Force with a country, according to Alar.

“The main defence of the gate is a defence field we can raise in the case of an unauthorised activation,” Farrell explained, pointing at a large device in the corner, with another guard behind a console next to it. “We adapted this after we heard about your iris.”

The Russians and Chinese had been talking shop, then - sharing Stargate Command’s experience. Jack hadn’t expected them to be that forthcoming with knowledge, even if it was knowledge the Air Force had earned before the two countries had forced themselves into Stargate Command. On the other hand, they might not want to risk the Goa’uld taking the planet before they had gotten all the technology they wanted.

“Oh! Is that a projector linked to your main shield generator, or does it form a defence field independently? Is it linked to your main generator, or does it have an autonomous power supply?” Entrapta was halfway to the thing before Carter managed to stop her.

Farrell raised her eyebrows at that but didn’t comment. The guards, though, looked a little twitchy. As did Tralan.

Alar, on the other hand, smiled at their group. “Come, I’ll show you around!”

The quick tour didn't much to refute Jack's impression; they passed through narrow tunnels that lacked any decor - and were pretty dark. Either the Eurondans were saving power or lacked the resources to add more lightbulbs. Or both.

But the vault Alar showed them - over the silent objection of Farrell; Jack recognised that expression when the Eurondan leader made a detour - was another thing. Huge, quite well lit - and full of thousands of 'stasis pods' stacked on each other. And each contained a Eurondan, waiting in stasis for the war to end.

Jack felt a shiver run down his spine at the sight. His friends looked queasy as well.

"This is what we are fighting for: Our people. For an entire generation, they have been asleep. They trusted us with their lives and future when they went into stasis," Alar said. "Look!" He walked over to a console and hit a few keys, flipping through half a dozen pictures of frozen people.

"Oh! Is this stasis like stopping time? Or slowing it down? Or did you freeze them?" Entrapta peered at the display, then pulled out her tool. "Oh! They are in a sort of suspended animation, I think - right Sam?" She held the tool out to Carter.

Carter flashed a quick, apologetic smile at Alar before glancing at the recorder-scanner-thingie. "Yes, it looks like suspended animation. Like hibernation," she added for those who weren't up to date on the latest technobabble.

Alar nodded. "Yes. Their bodies have slowed down, and they barely age during stasis."

"But they do age," Entrapta said. "It's not perfect stasis. So, you can't fight your war forever."

"We are aware of that," Alar said. His smile slipped a little.

"Oh, shouldn't I have said that? Sorry! It's still a bit hard to know when I'm supposed to talk about facts and when not. It's pretty

confusing."

"Confusing?" Alar blinked.

"The social coding about facts and data," Catra explained - or tried to; Alar didn't seem to follow her.

Adora cleared her throat. "Well, that's varies from culture to culture. But let's talk about how we can help you." She glanced at the rows of sleeping people. "Perhaps in a meeting room?"

Alar nodded. "Oh, let me show you our command room first!"

Ah! Jack perked up. Whether that was their actual command centre or just a fake one, this was bound to be interesting!

*****

Underground Base, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

The Eurondan command centre felt pretty packed, in Adora's opinion. A dozen soldiers were staring at screens and brightly lit map tables, barely looking up when Alar entered with Adora and her friends in tow.

"From here, we run the defence of our people!" Alar announced. "Our entire forces are coordinated here."

He didn't seem to mind Entrapta peering at the tables and screens, so Adora took a closer look as well. This was of professional interest, after all. The tables displayed a map of what Adora assumed was the main continent of Euronda. It was easy to see where the territory controlled by the Eurondans was - the entire area, in the centre of the continent, was covered with markers while the surrounding areas had much fewer markers. Their reconnaissance capability must be limited, she thought. They probably had no orbital assets to spy on their enemies' main areas.

Or that's what they want us to think, a small voice in the back of her mind which sounded like Catra's whispered.

But it didn't look staged to her. The people working here seemed genuinely busy and focused - few of them snuck glances at Adora and her friends. Entrapta, her hair lifting her up so she could look over the shoulders of the soldiers at the screens, and Isa, hanging back, her machine gun held loosely, drew the most attention.

"Airstrike detected!" a Eurondan announced.

A jolt seemed to go through the assembled soldiers as the screens flickered and the symbols on the tables changed.

"Bombers incoming."

The enemy symbols were close to their territory - if Adora had guessed the scale of the maps correctly, at least. Another sign that their sensor range was limited. And the poisoned surface would make scouting missions difficult. Surface attacks were impossible, according to Alar. Still, with both sides apparently focusing on the air war, a small surface scouting element might be effective if they had protective suits and the supplies to operate in a poisoned environment.

"Launching interception."

"Come!" Alar said. "Let me show you how we defend us against their bombers!"

He led them to the room next to the command centre - or the other half of the room; there was no clear separation. Several people were sitting in large chairs lining the wall, with some transparent canopies covering their upper bodies and consoles in front of them.

"These are our remote flyers. With them, a single pilot can control an entire formation of aero-fighter," Alar announced.

Adora blinked. So, the command centre wasn't just for the strategic control of their forces - they operated their forces directly from here as well? That was… unique. Not possible for the Alliance forces, though it presented advantages. You could use your best pilots for every attack, shuffling them around. But it also made them vulnerable to a decapitation strike - unless you had alternatives.

"Oh! How do they work? Radio transmitters, no doubt, but the signal density… Look, Sam! That's a magnitude above our own remote controls, even taking the superior data compression into account! That must be a direct neural interface."

"Correct," Alar said. "The aero-fighters are controlled directly by thought. The manual controls are a mere backup. Each pilot controls an entire squadron."

"Oh! And are the aero-fighters able to act autonomously?" Entrapta asked, beaming at him. "Like bots?"

"They cannot execute complex actions such as fighting," Farrell told her. "But they can stay aloft on autopilot. Emergency landings are possible as well, though unnecessary since if the autopilot engages, we can easily have a pilot take control of them for landing." He smiled. "Do you wish to try them out? The controls are intuitive. If you have any piloting experience, you will find them easy to use and effective to fight."

Adora blinked again. "You want us to take control of your craft in the middle of an attack?" He trusted them that much? No, he wanted them to fight their enemy!

Glimmer shook her head and gave Alar her 'I want to tell you what I really think, but I have to be polite right now' smile. "That would be considered an act of war against your enemy. We're here to end the war, not take sides in it."

"Nice try," Adora heard Catra mutter next to her.

Alar remained unfazed. “Of course. I apologise. You seemed so interested in our technology, I merely thought to let you try it out in actual action.” His own smile turned rueful. “We’ve been fighting this war for so long, it seemed normal to me, and I did not think about the political aspects of my offer.”

Catra softly snorted, and Adora agreed; she didn’t think this had slipped Alar’s mind. He was the leader of the Erondans, after all, and used to politics.

“Enemy bombers destroyed,” another soldier announced.

“Ollan is one of our best pilots,” Alar said, nodding at the soldier sitting in the remote flyer next to them.

“Nice shooting, I guess,” Jack said as the canopy rose.

Ollan just stared at him, though, without saying anything. His mouth was half-open, though…

After an awkward moment, Alar spoke up again: “Now, let me invite you to a meal. And, I hope, a fruitful discussion.”

*****

Samantha Carter didn’t want to have a meal and a discussion. She wanted to take another look at those ‘remote flyer’ consoles. She was a scientist, not a diplomat or a politician. But they were guests here, and if they wanted to have a chance at ending the war and helping the planet here, they would need the Eurondans’ cooperation.

She still glanced back at Ollan as they left the command centre. The pilot was staring at the wall, his face blank.

Sam had seen soldiers before who had cracked from traumatic experiences, but they didn’t look like Ollan. The Eurondan pilot seemed functional, but… empty was probably the best word. He was just sitting there, not showing any reaction or emotion. Burnt out, she thought.

She wouldn't have expected this in a war fought primarily by remote-controlled drone fighters. Was the experience of flying a fighter in combat through a neural interface that much more personal, that much harsher and more terrible? She itched to examine the technology to find out.

But Alar led them into a smallish dining room with elaborately carved chairs lining a long table. If not for the darker lighting, this could have been a formal dinner on Earth.

"Oh! There's no chair for Isa?" Entrapta asked.

Sam glanced down the table. Her friend was correct - she didn't see a chair large enough for Isa to sit in comfortably. Not unexpected since all the Eurondan they had seen so far were of average size.

Alar looked momentarily surprised - and concerned, Sam noted. "I was under the impression that the… woman was your guard."

"Isa is assigned to our security, yes," the General cut in.

Isa nodded with a grunt from where she and Campbell had already taken up guard positions at the wall, facing two Eurondan guards.

Alar smiled, apparently relieved. "Good. Please, sit down!"

The meal was worse than Sam had expected. It was a thin soup and a pudding-like substance that made tofu taste spicy. Seasonings and spices would be very profitable trade goods, Sam couldn't help thinking.

"Yeah, should have taken an MRE," she heard the General mutter.

"I've eaten worse," Catra commented. "Back in the Horde."

"The brown rations," Adora agreed. Both shared a smile.

That would mean they considered the grey rations better than this, Sam knew. Damning with faint praise, indeed.

Daniel, though, showed no revulsion. He dug into the meal - though that was likely more his interest in a new culture and civilisation than the taste. Sam hoped so, at least. "I've never had such a meal before," he said, smiling at Alar.

Sha're nodded. "It's exotic."

Alar smiled at Daniel. "As I said, it's a sacrifice we all make for the war effort. A tiny sacrifice compared to that of our people in stasis, though."

"Earth has several examples of meals that were originally the result of poor resources yet became loved cornerstones of a culture's cuisine," Daniel told him. "Like the Italian cucina povera, literally the 'kitchen of the poor'."

"My people would never waste food as long as it was edible, no matter the taste," Sha're added. Daniel took a little while to get used to that when we lived on Abydos.

Daniel beamed at her. "You made everything taste good, my dear."

Sha're snorted. "Flatterer."

Sam's smile slipped when she saw Alar briefly scowl at the couple. Had Daniel managed to insult the man without meaning to? But he hadn't reacted to the General's far more blunt comment…

"Are you… in a relationship?" Alar asked with a strained smile.

"We're married," Daniel replied, putting his hand over Sha're's.

Sha're nodded. "We were separated for years due to our enemies but were reunited some time ago."

"So, it is true - your culture is a 'melting pot', as the Russians and Chinese called it," Farrell said. The woman's smile was very thin as

well, Sam noticed.

What was the issue?

"Well, the United States has been called that," the General said with a casual shrug that Sam knew was entirely faked. "We're a nation built by immigrants from all over the world."

"And the Alliance is formed by many countries working together against a common enemy," Glimmer added. "As was the Princess Alliance on Etheria."

"I see." Alar slowly nodded. Then his eyes widened in obvious surprise.

He was looking at Adora and Catra, Sam realised. The two were also holding hands; Catra probably felt the need to show off after Daniel and Sha're had drawn attention.

Alar *shuddered*. Sam saw him grab his glass and drink deeply from the watered-down liquor served to the meal, taking deep breaths and still barely managing to smile again - politely - when he set the glass down.

He made a point of focusing on the General - and on Sam, she realised with a sinking feeling.

*****

Catra was tempted to smirk at Alar. So, the leader of the Eurondans had a problem with Adora's and her love? Too bad for him! Just like the bigots on Earth, they needed the Alliance far more than the Alliance needed them. The Alliance actually didn't need them at all - well, the medical technology could save lives, or so the preliminary analysis told them, and the data compression had Sam and Entrapta excited, but the Eurondans had admitted that they needed heavy water to defend themselves or they'd lose the war.

On the other hand, Adora really wanted to stop the war here to save lives and restore the planet. Catra understood that. From a certain point of view, the Eurondans looked a lot like the Horde. Terrible rations, surrounded by a poisoned environment, everything and everyone focused on the war, and no civilians to worry about. The Eurondans weren't trying to conquer the planet. Instead, they were defending themselves, but the Horde had been on the backfoot a few times during the war as well.

She blinked, not even pouting as Adora withdrew her hand to continue eating. Who actually had started the war on Euronda? Alar had been a little vague about the whole thing, hadn't he? Just like the Horde instructors, he had focused on the current situation in the war, the Alliance's actions and forces, and what to do about them, not the causes of the war itself. Of course, everyone - except for Adora the dummy - had known that the Horde had started it and was trying to conquer Etheria, so that hadn't been necessary or useful, but… The similarities between the Horde and the Eurondans were pretty striking, weren't they?

She looked at Alar. He was talking to Jack and Sam about aero-fighters. Apparently, they used the same principles as the Air Force planes - no anti-gravity technology or magic. And he wasn't looking at anyone else. Even when Bow added something technical or Teal'c commented on the tactical uses of Death Gliders, Alar barely glanced at them.

That was weird.

"Are you a couple?" Farrell suddenly asked Adora. The woman looked tense - her smile was barely there, her lips pressed together, and Catra half-expected to hear her grinding her teeth.

Adora, though, beamed at her and nodded. "Yes, we are!" Catra's lover reached over again and squeezed Catra's hand.

Catra flashed her fangs at Farrell and leaned into Adora's side to rub it in. Bigots hated that!

“Ah.” Farrell took a sip from her glass.

Catra hadn’t touched hers since the first sip. She had had better from a still in the cadet’s barracks.

“I assume when you’re not fighting a war for your people’s survival, you don’t have to care about having children,” Farrell went on.

Children? Was that what this was about? Catra glanced at Adora, who looked taken aback. They hadn’t talked about children! Not with each other. And they certainly wouldn’t start discussing children with the Eurondans! Catra was tempted to mention Luna as their baby. Entrapta probably had a picture of the kitten at hand in her tool.

Bow, though, must have overheard yet missed the context or tension since he leaned over with a smile. “Oh, if you want kids but can’t rely on, ah, natural conception or adoption, you can use magitech to combine your genes and have the baby grown in a womb - artificial or natural. My Dads did that.”

“Yes! Etheira had had the basic technology since the first royal lines started - a relic of the First Ones genetic engineering, I think,” Entrapta chimed in. “And now, with the Horde clone technology and Alpha’s data, we can pretty much combine any genes no matter the species! Hordak and I haven’t yet decided if we’ll have kids, but we’ve run a few simulations to check possible appearances and designs.” She smiled widely as she pushed a few buttons on her multitool, and a small projection of a child-Hordak with long dark purple hair appeared, followed by a child version of Entrapta with Hordak’s skin tone and eyes. “See?”

Farrell gasped. She was staring at the projection as if it was the most horrible thing she had ever seen. “This… this…this is…” She shook her head. “How can you do this?”

“Oh, easily with genetic engineering!” Entrapta replied without looking at Farrell. She was smiling at the projections instead.

“That’s how a lot of Etheria’s population was created, you know? By First Ones scientists combining different species! It’s kind of a tradition, you might say - and so exciting!”

The whole table was now looking at them, Catra noticed. Her friends looked a bit annoyed or embarrassed, but all of the Eurondans looked horrified. Even the guards back at the wall.

“Ah…” Daniel cleared his throat. “I guess genetic engineering is not practised on your world?” he asked with a forced smile.

“We don’t breed uncontrollably!” Farrell spat. “We maintain genetic purity!”

Wait... Catra blinked. Breed? They call their enemies ‘*Breeders*’. “And your enemies don’t, right?”

The table was silent.

*****

Oh, damn! That explained the attitude of the Eurondans that Jack O’Neill had picked up. The way they had glanced at the Etherians. And at Teal’c. And Daniel and Sha’re. ‘Genetic purity’ indeed!

“They breed indiscriminately,” Alar said after a moment. “Mixing their genes with no thought! Tainting their own people! Their legacy!” He spat out each word with a sneer. “They are impure!”

Yeah, Jack had heard - or read - that kind of speech before. Just replace ‘genes’ with ‘blood’, and it would fit perfectly into the Third Reich.

Daniel had grown pale but was rapidly recovering - and frowning. Sha’re looked puzzled. The Etherians looked shocked, but their expressions were changing as well as realisation set in, Jack saw.

Except for Entrapta. “But that makes no sense. That’s not how it works. Genetic diversity is a good thing. Otherwise, you get inbreeding.”

“Inbreeding?” Farrell scowled at her.

“Yes. That happens when people who are too closely related, genetically related, reproduce. Over a few generations, genetic defects start to accumulate,” Entrapta explained. “In extreme cases, you might end up with genetic degradation, like the Asgard, though in their case, it was imperfect cloning that was the source since they had stopped reproducing sexually long ago.”

Farrell scoffed. “Such defects are a sign of impurity. Maintaining genetic purity relies on culling any weaknesses to create the perfect people.”

Jack wasn’t a geneticist, but he had looked into things, a little - after discovering that he had some Ancient genes, Jack would have been a fool not to read up on what it meant - and that sounded even worse.

Entrapta gasped. “But imperfection is beautiful! If everything is perfect, you cannot experiment! Science would be useless!” She shook her head, her hair tendrils flailing. “There is no perfect people; that is not how science works. That’s not how life works!”

“What could be considered a weakness in some circumstances might be a strength in others,” Daniel added.

The Eurondans were scowling at both.

Jack pressed his lips together and eyed the room. Pissing off their hosts, no matter how much they deserved it, wasn’t a good idea when you were in the middle of their base, alone on their world, without a fleet in orbit.

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “You need data for science. The more data, the better! And diversity creates more data! If everyone is the same, you won’t have any variance to experiment with! Nothing new to discover! No competition!”

Now, that sounded a little concerning as well to Jack. At least it would if it came from, say, Loki or Hordak. He made a mental

note that he would have to check up on what exactly they were doing in their lab with Alpha.

"You are wrong! Strength is found in purity. In unity!" Farrell's voice was rising. Not quite screeching, but Entrapta must have hit a nerve. "Impurities weaken a people! Like impurities weaken materials!"

"Actually, many alloys are far stronger than their pure components," Carter cut in, then frowned.

"The whole is often greater than the sum of its parts," Daniel agreed.

They were correct, of course, but they were arguing with fanatics. And Jack might not be a scientist, but he had experience with zealots. Logic didn't work with them.

And it didn't work here either. "We have maintained our genetic purity for generations and have been proven stronger for it!" Alar snapped. "We know the truth!"

Jack couldn't resist. "Yet, you are losing the war to the 'Breeders', aren't you? Seems to me that they're proving to be stronger."

"They have the advantage of numbers and benefitted from a few miscalculations on our side," Alar retorted. "That is not strength. That is mere luck."

"Sounds like you're making up excuses," Catra said with a snort. "Trust me, that's not going to work. You can't win a war by ignoring facts because you don't like them."

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "Data doesn't lie!"

"We will prevail! We almost won the war before, and we will finish it with a victory!" Alar spat. "We will not let the Breeders wipe us out!"

"You'd rather destroy the world than let them win, huh?" Catra scoffed again, shaking her head - and then froze for a moment.

Jack felt a cold shiver run down his spine - the Eurondans were nodding. "Just how did the surface end up poisoned?" he asked. It couldn't… but it would fit. "Was that a 'miscalculation'?"

Alar glanced at Farrell for a moment. "We had no choice. They were breeding indiscriminately. Spreading their taint all over the world. We could not let them take over and wipe us out. And they were not listening. They would not listen - they would not change! My father realised that we had only one choice left. Unfortunately, we were too late, and they managed to preserve enough forces and resources to press us hard."

"You started this war?" Glimmer gasped.

"We had no choice. They were breeding and would have wiped us out if we hadn't acted. The longer we waited, the worse our situation would grow," Alar retorted. "We had waited too long already, or we would have won the war with our preemptive strike."

Hell! They were even more like the Nazis than Jack had feared.

He really wanted to shoot Alar right now.

*****

The Eurondans had started the war? And they had poisoned their own world to kill their enemies? Adora shook her head. She couldn't believe it! It was… monstrous! "How could you do that? Destroy your own world to kill your enemies?"

She saw Catra flinch next to her and winced. Of course, that would remind her lover of the portal that had almost destroyed Etheria! She squeezed Catra's hand but focused on Alar.

"We are facing an existential threat," Alar replied. "If we lose the war, our people will perish. If we had not poisoned the surface,

we would have lost the war - and our world with it. Sacrificing what you will lose anyway is not a difficult decision."

Adora shook her head again. Alar made it sound as if wrecking an entire world - poisoning the air and soil - was logical. Rational. Simple. It wasn't! "And you started the war!"

Alar scoffed. "We had no choice. The Breeders were growing stronger and more numerous with every day that passed. What else could we have done but striking as long as there was still a chance of victory instead of assured defeat?"

"Our enemies depended on the resources on the surface much more than we did," Farrell added. "We were prepared for this while they weren't."

"And it still wasn't enough to win," Jack said in a flat voice. "You miscalculated."

"As long as we can get heavy water, we can win this war," Farrell told him. "Our people are in stasis, waiting for us."

"And once you win, you'll wipe out your enemy?" Daniel asked.

"They are trying to eradicate our people. Erase our way of life," Alar said. "If they win this war, they'll do the same to us."

"I'll take that as a 'yes'," Jack said. He looked at Adora.

She clenched her teeth. She wouldn't let them murder the Breeders - the Eurondan Alliance. But she couldn't let the Eurondans be murdered either. Everyone deserved a second chance. A chance to change. "The war will end," she said. "Without either side winning."

Alar shook his head. "You cannot end the war like that. It has been waged for decades. Too many have died. It's either the Breeders or us."

"Well, you started it," Jack said.

"Jack!" Daniel frowned at him, then turned to look at Alar. "Peace is possible."

"Yes!" Entrapta said. "The Horde and the Princess Alliance also fought for decades, technically, at least, and now we're at peace! And we're cleaning up the environmental damage done to the Fright Zone, working together. Although the Alliance arguably won the war. But we didn't kill the Horde. We're friends now!"

Adora heard Catra softly scoff at that. But Entrapta was right - they were at peace. And while Adora knew that some grudges remained, the majority of both former Horde and Alliance members were working together now. Of course, many former soldiers of Hordak's Horde had switched sides at a point before Horde Prime's defeat, which certainly helped with that.

But even the Clones had joined the Alliance after Horde Prime's end - at least the Clones they knew about - so it was possible for enemies to become allies. They just needed a chance.

She firmly nodded. "We can and will end this war." Even if they had to send a fleet here. Which they hopefully wouldn't have to. "We'll talk to your enemies. And we'll restore your world."

"And then? The Breeders will wipe us out as soon as they have the chance!" Farrell protested.

"We won't let them start a war. Or you," Glimmer said.

"Left alive, they'll overwhelm us sooner or later," Alar said. "They don't need to wage war for this."

Adora frowned. That made no sense. "What do you mean? They'll destroy you by… living?"

"They will destroy us by breeding uncontrollably," Alar explained. "Mixing genes indiscriminately. Rendering our people impure. We'll vanish, our entire way of life fading as they take over Euronda."

"And good riddance," Jack muttered under his breath.

Adora blinked. Was Alar serious? “Are you saying they’ll… force you to have children with them?” That would be rape!

“Of course they will!” Farrell spat.

“We won’t let them do that to you,” Glimmer said. “What do you think we are, monsters?”

Alar exchanged a glance with Farrell before he replied: “Will you force us to allow interbreeding with the Breeders?”

Oh, no! Adora scowled at them. As did her friends. “We won’t let you keep people from loving whoever they want,” she said. “If one of your people and one of the Eurondan Alliance want to be together, they’ll be allowed to.”

“Just as we were warned by the Russians and Chinese! You want to destroy our way of life as well!” Alar said.

“If your way of life means keeping people from loving who they want, then it deserves to be destroyed!” Glimmer spat.

“That will destroy our people!” Alar had stood up and was glaring at them. Then he glanced at the guards behind him. “We have no choice.”

What did he… Adora’s eyes widened. No!

She jumped up, her chair falling down behind her. “Don’t…!”

But before she could finish, Catra pounced on Alar, reaching for his hand.

Adora caught a glimpse of a device he held a moment before the alarm went off.

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Spy Games Part 8

Underground Base, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

One moment, they were talking. The next, all hell broke loose. Samantha Carter was already moving when the alarm went off. She threw herself out of her chair and dragged Entrapta to the floor.

"For the Honour of Grayskull!"

Adora's yell and Entrapta's surprised gasp were both drowned out by Isa's machine gun, followed by more shots ringing out.

Samantha Carter kept her head down and drew her zat. No one under the table - wait! Someone was on the floor! She aimed her weapon before she realised that it was a body chewed up by automatic fire. She twisted, checking the other end of the table. More corpses.

And the shooting had stopped.

"Secure that door!"

"Yes, sir!"

A moment later, something heavy slammed against something metal.

Sam got up, zat still in hand. The guards and half the Eurondans at the table were dead, cut down by Isa, Campbell and the General. Alar was on his knees, holding his bleeding right hand with his other hand. Sam caught a glimpse of two fingers on the floor.

Farrell was still in her seat, slumped over. Stunned. No, dead - Sam saw the blood dripping down the legs of the chair.

Isa and Campbell were at the door, Isa holding it closed with her sheer bulk. Daniel was getting up from under Sha're, and Teal'c was keeping watch over another surviving Eurondan, zat aimed at it.

And Catra was holding up a small device half-covered in blood. "He pressed the button on this before I could stop him."

"Oh! Looks like a communicator!" Entrapta said, peering at the device as her hair grabbed it. "Let's check!"

"That's how you return our hospitality?" Alar said, panting. "By murdering us during a diplomatic meeting?"

"You were about to attack us," Catra spat.

"I was about to order you to leave!" Alar retorted.

"Yeah, right." The General shook his head. "That's why you were triggering the alarm."

"We need to move!" Glimmer said. "The base is on alert - the guards will come at us."

"We've got the leader. Will that keep them from throwing bombs at us?" Catra asked.

"Ah… it is hard to say without knowing more about the society of our, uh, former hosts," Daniel replied. "It also depends on whether or not Alar has rivals waiting for the opportunity to remove him and blame foreigners for it."

"The people are loyal!" Alar spat. "We know our duty."

"And we know ours," the General said. "Let's get out of here before we get trapped."

"To the gate?" Campbell asked.

“No.” The General grinned. “We’ll need a diversion to reach it. And what better diversion than their command centre getting destroyed?”

“No! You can’t!” Alar gasped. “The Breeders will murder us all!”

“We’ll be back home before that,” the General replied.

“We can’t let them continue their war,” Adora said.

Sam half-expected the General to make a comment about how they totally could, but he just sighed. “I hoped you wouldn’t say that.”

“Jack!”

“Daniel!”

Adora moved to the door, and her sword became a shield. “I’ll check the hallway,” she said.

She had barely opened the door when Sam heard what had to be the firing noise of Eurondan weapons, and Adora’s shield was hit by multiple beams. The door shook as well, cracking in several places.

“Not exactly the best shots,” the General commented.

“You are trapped in here!” Alar yelled.

“Shows what you know,” Catra told him. “Didn’t the Russians and Chinese warn you about us?”

“They told us about your technology!”

But not their magic? Sam raised her eyebrows. Either the Russians and Chinese had been setting up the Eurondans or the Eurondans hadn’t believed them.

“We need to leave, sir,” Lenkova spoke up. “We can take Alar with us.”

Sam glanced at the Eurondan leader, expecting him to protest. But he was grinning. That was a remarkable mood shift… Oh.

She grabbed her scanner and aimed it at the door. A glance at the screen confirmed her suspicion: "There's a force field blocking our way."

"What?" The General glared at Alar.

The man grinned toothly at him.

"They might have taken the one from their gate room," Bow speculated. "Or used another one."

"Whatever - we need to get out of here," Catra said.

Sam agreed. But how? "We could cut through the walls, but… the field is quite powerful and might expand to cover such holes in the area as well."

"Oh, yes. Depending on the projector technology, the shield could do that," Entrapta said. "We should test it!"

Catra frowned but stepped up to the wall, lashing out with her claws, then kicked the material.

A piece of the material fell back and down, revealing the round hole Catra had slashed into the wall. No shots rang out from the other side.

And when Sam used her scanner again, it confirmed the presence of a force field.

"We're locked in here," she said.

"Shit."

*****

Catra eyed the ceiling. They might have set up a field to cover the walls, but did they extend it to the top? They probably had, but

best to make sure.

She jumped on the table, which creaked but held under her weight - it was sporting a few new holes from the firefight - and raked her claws on the ceiling, carving out a piece of it. Catra jumped off the table a moment before the jagged mass of the piece smashed and broke it.

“That’s also covered by a force field,” Sam reported.

“Had to check,” Catra said. “Would have been terribly embarrassing if we had missed the easy way out.”

Jack snorted at that. “What about the floor?”

Catra was about to bend down, but Adora had her sword out and swung it in a circle. The cut material stayed - propped up by another force field. Or… “Is that the same forcefiled, or one each?” Catra asked.

“The spectrum of the fields is exactly the same,” Entrapta replied. “That doesn’t mean that it’s the same field - their projectors could just have tight tolerances.”

“They’re massing outside,” Isa reported.

“They’ll have to drop the shield if they want to hurt us,” Jack told her. “And if they can hurt us, we can hurt them.”

“Or they try to poison us,” Glimmer pointed out.

Catra glanced at Alar. The man had his lips pressed together, but she didn’t know him enough to tell if that meant this was a possibility. Best assume it was - they had almost died because of Eurondan poison before, and it was obvious that they liked using such means.

“Mask up then,” Jack said, reaching into a pocket of his uniform.

Catra slipped a hand inside her own uniform and pulled out her own mask - a new design by Entrapta that could be folded up until it was hardly bigger than a handkerchief thanks to new filters. It would help with a gas attack but wouldn't stop nerve gas.

So, they had to get away quickly. And since Glimmer couldn't teleport without Adora releasing the planet's magic, which she wouldn't do until she was ready to use the boost to save the world… "Walls, floor or ceiling?" Catra asked.

Adora eyed the ceiling.

"We did that in Apophis's palace," Jack said. "Let's try the wall."

The command centre was on this floor - and roughly on the way to the gate room. Catra grinned.

Adora slowly nodded. She had her 'determined face' on. That meant she wouldn't let anything stop her, Catra knew.

"You can't get through our defence field!" Alar snapped. "You should surrender!"

"You haven't seen anything," Glimmer told him.

Adora nodded again, then stepped to the door, holding out her sword. "Hah!" She swung it with both hands, striking at the force field. The blade hit in a shower of sparks, and Catra saw flickers appear in the air as Adora lifted the sword for another strike.

"Field strength is fluctuating," Sam reported. "Stabilising… at a lower strength." She moved her scanner.

"Just hit it until it breaks," Catra translated.

But Adora was already dishing out a flurry of blows, striking so rapidly that the entire door area was covered in sparks, obscuring the view of the waiting enemy.

Alar was staring, open-mouthed, at the sight, and Catra grabbed his collar to drag him out of the potential line of fire - he was, after all, a potential hostage as the enemy leader. And for later negotiations, probably.

Jack was pulling Lenkova to the side as well - judging from her earlier position, the woman probably still needed to understand that you shouldn't try to charge ahead of a princess.

Catra checked the ceiling. The field there was holding steady, no sparks or even flickers. So, different shield projectors, then.

And then suddenly, the sparks disappeared as the shield shattered. A second later, the Eurondan soldiers opened fire with their beam guns, but Adora had already changed her sword into a shield. Catra saw half the beams miss her lover as Adora charged down the hallway, straight into the enemy's ranks.

The Eurondans broke ranks even before Adora smashed into and through them, Catra noted as she sped after her. They must not have much, if any, experience with infantry combat, she thought as she kicked a dazed soldier in the head, knocking him into the wall behind him before he could reach for the gun he had dropped.

Another one was screaming and holding his broken leg - she could see parts of the bone sticking out through his pants - and Catra knocked him out as well.

She caught Daniel stunning the man for good measure as the rest of the group followed in their wake, Teal'c carrying Alar and Isa bringing up the rear and covering side alleys with Campbell.

Those two had no intention of getting ahead of a charging princess, Catra noted. Good - Jack was training his people well.

Half a minute later, they had cleared the area of any enemies and were standing in front of a big blast door.

Adora raised her sword, then hesitated. “They’ll expect us to go through the door.”

“And we can’t count on them acting like the ones we went just through,” Catra added.

She looked up at the ceiling, then at the walls.

“We need to check if they deploy poison.” Before running into it.

*****

Jack O’Neill cursed under his breath. Of course, the Space Nazis would use gas. If only they could have brought NBC suits along - but not even Carter, Entrapta and Bow working together would have been able to build protective suits that could be concealed like those new masks. Maybe he should take another look at the proposal for new uniforms for Alliance troops that doubled as NBC and vacuum suits with a helmet added, even if they looked like Horde uniforms…

But you fought a war with the gear you had, not the gear you wished you had. “Carter?” He cocked his head at his second-in-command.

“Working on it, sir. Our scanners don’t show any poison gas, but given the known capability of the Eurondans to create a gas that evades detection, we cannot exclude the possibility of another such case.”

Jack eyed Alar. The Space Führer looked confused for a moment, then his eyes widened. So, whatever poison the Eurondans used, they were unaware of its effect on Alliance scanners.

But that didn’t tell Jack whether or not they had such poison. “No bombs?”

“No explosive devices detected in range, sir,” Carter reported. “Not with advanced technology or sufficient conventional explosive filler to function as a hand grenade.”

That was one worry less. Unless… "Incendiaries?" he asked.

Carter blinked, then started pushing buttons on her scanner.

As soon as Jack saw her jaw muscles twitch, showing she was clenching her teeth, he knew he had been correct.

"They are concentrating fuel tanks on the other side, sir. I expected them to use hydrogen as fuel since they have fusion reactors, but this seems to be a fuel based on ethanol - distilled from the yeast they are growing in hydroponics, I assume."

"Probably," he agreed. Not that it mattered. What mattered was that they were about to burn if they forced the door. And not even Adora's shield would keep the heat back. It was already quite the break that the Eurondans weren't sucking the air out of the rooms. Maybe their bunker wasn't set up for that - they were pretty inexperienced with infantry combat.

The others looked concerned as well. Most of them, at least.

"OK… so, no forcing the door, Adora," Bow said.

"Ceiling?" Catra looked up.

"They're moving fuel up there as well," Entrapta announced.

The bastards are learning quickly, Jack thought. Of course, they might suck at infantry tactics, but they are probably naturals when it came to poison attacks and other war crimes, he reminded himself.

"Down then?"

"The level below seems clear, sir," Carter confirmed.

"Or we unblock magic, and I port us to the Stargate," Glimmer suggested.

Adora shook her head. “Not yet. We might need that power to save the planet.”

That was fine - Jack would rather avoid being too close to Adora channelling a planet’s worth of magic again. He didn’t want to be turned into a plant - or an alien. “We’re going down, then!”

“Jack!”

Jack chuckled at his friend’s reaction, as did others. Spirits lifted, mission accomplished. “Let’s hurry before the Space Nazis decide that their dear leader is an acceptable sacrifice to kill us.”

Alar glared at him. “I will gladly die for my people!”

“Be my guest,” Jack retorted with a shrug. The odds of the Eurondans being willing to negotiate were probably higher if they could blame everything on a conveniently dead leader. Not that Jack would trust them, anyway - after a decade or two of waging total war against ‘racial enemies’, their indoctrination would be hard to overcome. At least without utterly crushing their army like the Allies had done to the Nazis.

“Hah!” Adora slashed at the floor again, carving out a round section. Then she stuck her sword into it, bent down - and heaved it up with a grunt.

Alar was gaping at the display. Jack snorted - if he knew just how strong She-Ra was, he would probably piss himself. Or start worshipping her as an Aryan goddess or something.

Adora made short work of the force field covering the floor with a few more strikes, then jumped down, quickly followed by Catra.

Jack heard someone screaming, followed by a crash, before he reached the hole. He gripped the edge and lowered himself down before dropping. He wasn’t some magical princess or catwoman, and his knees wouldn’t stay healthy if he tried to imitate either.

He landed in a crouch, scanning the room with his gun out, but Adora and Catra had already taken down the Eurondan guards here. This seemed to be a storage room - he could see stacks of metal parts. Aero-Flyer parts, from the looks of it. No missiles or what looked like weapons, though. As far as he could tell, at least.

Behind him, Entrapta followed, carrying Carter in her hair. Then Teal'c jumped down with Alar, followed by the rest of their group.

"Which way?" Jack asked. There were two doors here. One led towards the direction of the Stargate, but that didn't have to mean anything in a bunker.

Carter and Etrapta used their scanners. "There are two lifts close to this room. One large, one smaller," Carter reported.

The large would be to transport the stuff in here to wherever they were doing maintenance of their planes. "Let's take the large one," Jack said. "Might take some of the parts here with us as cover."

"Good idea. We should…"

"Shh!" Catra snapped, interrupting Bow. Her ears twitched. Then she sniffed the air - and hissed. "They're pouring fuel into the area above us."

Damn! He had been right about those bastards! "Let's hurry - I don't want to end up in a Eurondan barbecue!" Jack clenched his teeth and rushed towards the closer door.

*****

Adora gasped and stepped below the hole she had cut in the floor - the ceiling now. She couldn't see any liquid yet, but she trusted Catra… oh, there it was. Dripping down the hole. "It's just a trickle now, but that won't last!" she yelled. And once the Eurondans ignited it…

“Can you stop it?” Sam asked. “The fumes are explosive. If it fills the room…”

Adora drew a sharp breath - and smelt alcohol. Clenching her teeth, she quickly eyed the opening. If she changed her sword into a large shield, she could plug the hole. Most of it. It wouldn’t be perfect, but it should stop the fuel from reaching the storage room. Or… She looked to the side. Yes.

She grabbed a batch of armour plates and pushed them below the hole, then grabbed the uppermost plate and jumped on the stack. The fuel was falling down the hole now, drenching her. She raised the plate above her - and pressed it against the opening.

The stream slowed down to a trickle, quickly filling the hole above her and weighing down on the plate. She could take it tough - she was She-Ra.

“Open the doors!” Jack said.

“We need to hack the electronic locks,” Entrapta said. “And their systems are good - better than Goa’uld technology.”

Catra sniffed the air again. “We’re getting fumes inside here.”

Adora bared her teeth. She couldn’t help that - the plate wasn’t a perfect seal. The fuel trickling in formed a growing puddle beneath her.

“Can’t you just slice it open?” she heard Daniel ask.

“If we do that, the fuel will follow us through the hole,” Catra retorted.

“And if it starts burning, it will suck the air from outside in,” Bow added. “Or blow up.”

“The Eurondans must be crazy to try this!” Daniel blurted out.

“They probably don’t realise that we’ve cut a hole into the floor,” Sha’re replied. “But even so, the damage to the level above us would be extensive.”

Jack cursed. “Hurry!”

“We’re working as fast as we can, sir.” Sam sounded stressed.

Adora felt stressed. The weight on the armour plate was growing rapidly - it was getting harder to keep the pressure on to seal the opening above her. She could take it, though. She had to do it. Her friends depended on her. She wouldn’t let them down!

“There are some parallels to the software used against the Stargate Command,” Entrapta said - she sounded intrigued rather than stressed, Adora noted. “But it’s only superficial. I think the software there was heavily adapted to First Ones technology while this is completely native Eurondan architecture.”

“Whatever it is, solve it!” Jack snapped. “If alcohol has to kill me, it should be an expensive whisky. Not some cheap alien fuel.”

Adora snorted at that - and almost fumbled her grip on the shield. The puddle of fuel below her was spreading, reaching the stacks of supplies next to her. “Just how much fuel are they using for this?” she snapped.

“They’re fanatics,” Jack replied. “Probably everything they have.”

“That might hinder their aero-fighter strikes,” Bow said.

“I don’t think they care about that while we’re threatening to destroy their command centre,” Glimmer retorted.

“Carter, how much longer?” Jack asked. He sounded urgent, and when Adora glanced at him, she saw that he was staring at the fuel that was slowly spreading.

“Help me with this!” Catra snapped. She was dragging poles - pipes - with her. To prop up the armour plate, Adora realised.

Jack and Teal'c jumped to help, dropping Alar on the ground in the process. The man hissed with pain.

"I… ngh… don't think the poles will hold," Adora said.

"If we get enough, they will!" Catra insisted.

"They will help, at least," Jack said.

Adora doubted it. But her friends did their best to jam the pipes between the stack of armour plates below her and the one she was holding up.

"They are a bit too long," Jack said.

"Not any more," Catra snapped, slicing through them.

All three grunted and pushed the first pole into place, wedging it against the armour.

Adora barely felt a change but held her tongue. She could still take it, anyway. She had to. She had endured worse.

"OK! Let's get more!" Catra was already speeding off to grab more poles.

"Carter, how's it looking?"

"We're making progress, sir."

That was good. More poles joined the first ones as Isa helped as well. The fuel puddle was still spreading, but that couldn't be helped. It was covering half the floor now.

"If only we had some sealant…" Jack looked around.

"There might be something," Catra said. "But I can't tell from the labels."

Jack turned to Alar. "If you don't want to burn with us, you better help us out."

“I will gladly sacrifice my life for the people!” Alar spat. He sounded terrified, though.

But Adora had to focus on holding up the armour plate. How much longer until they had the door open? She could still hold out, but the pressure was increasing.

“Done!” Entrapta announced.

Adora gasped. Done!

“Or not!”

No!

“Wait - *that*’s the command to open it!”

Adra heard metal sliding over metal, followed by cheering. The door was opening! Yes!

But Catra cursed, staring at the ceiling. “They set it off!”

No!

“Everyone out!” Jack yelled. “Go! Go! Go!”

Adora turned to look at Catra. “Go!”

Her love wasn’t moving. “What about you?”

“I’ll jump once everyone is clear!” Adora said. “The poles will hold long enough.”

Catra stared at her, then jumped up to her.

Adora wanted to protest, to tell her to run, but before she could say a word, Catra kissed her. “Don’t die!” she whispered.

Then she turned and raced to the door, splashing through the puddle.

Adora strained. Was the armour plate growing hotter? Or was that her imagination? Could the fuel be burning that fast? Could it burn past the plate while there was still liquid above her?

"We're out!" Catra yelled. "Come!"

"Close the door!" Adora yelled. "Start to close it!"

"No!"

Adora hissed through clenched teeth: "I'll make it before it closes! Start it!"

"Close the door!" Jack snapped.

Adora heard the doors starting to close. Saw them moving. Guessed the speed. And the distance. If she was wrong, her friends would die. She wouldn't let them.

A bit longer… a little bit… Now!

She jumped, clearing half the room. Metal screeched behind her as she touched down in the puddle and launched herself forward, towards the door.

Catra was in the shrinking opening, staring wide-eyed at her. The sound of roaring, falling fluid filled the room as Adora flew towards her. The doors were almost closed - she could only see Catra standing there. A bright light lit up behind Adora, turning Catra even paler.

Adora hit the door, one shoulder scraping against the metal.

She hit Catra, grabbing her, rolling over the floor, curled around her lover.

Then she heard the explosion go off.

*****

Samantha Carter threw herself to the side when the storage room exploded, closing her eyes at the flash, waiting for the heat.

It didn't come. She looked up and saw the doors had closed completely and held. They were dented and buckled, and there was a burning patch of fuel in the middle, where the shockwave must have pushed burning fuel through the gap as it closed, but they had held.

She pushed herself up and looked at the group. Adora was up already, staring at the burning fuel, then at the doors. Catra was running a hand through her hair and frowning - both must be covered in fuel. Like Alar, whom Teal'c was dragging away from the burning puddle.

"Well, that was exciting. Let's not do it again and get back to the Stargate," the General said. "And see if we can get a shower on the way before a spark lights us up."

"Or before the fire reduces the doors' structural integrity too much," Entrapta added, looking up from her multitool.

Sam glanced at the screen and winced. The doors were rapidly heating up - the storage room must be an inferno. But that meant… "The ventilation must still be working, feeding oxygen to the fire!" she blurted out. Why hadn't the Eurondans shut that down?

It was a stupid question - they wanted to burn the group. But they risked dooming themselves. The ventilation could spread explosive vapours and poisonous smoke throughout the bunker if the filters couldn't handle it - or caught fire. "We need to move quickly!" she said.

"That's what I said," the General had to comment.

"Where is the closest bathroom?" Glimmer asked as they started moving towards the larger lift.

Sam tried to remember the floor plan she had derived from their scanners, but she hadn't paid attention to those facilities. An obvious mistake in hindsight.

"There's a toilet up ahead!" Entrapta, able to check her own screen while being carried by her hair, replied. A moment later, a projection appeared in the air, showing the layout of the floor they were on, with a blinking symbol. It was close indeed - around the next corner.

"OK! Everyone who's soaked with fuel, wash it off. The rest, move ahead to secure the lift!" the General snapped.

"That includes you, sir," Sam pointed out when he was about to move past the washroom - he had helped shore up the improvised plug Adora had used and so had been splashed with fuel, if not exactly soaked.

Before he could say something stupid, Adora reverted to her normal form, her soaked armour disappearing. Why would…?

"For the Honour of Grayskull!"

Ah. She was back as She-Ra - in dry armour. "I'll secure the lift!" she said - and sped off.

"I really have to revisit that uniform proposal," Sam heard the General mutter as they entered the bathroom.

Washing the fuel off - or, at least, diluting it sufficiently so the danger of catching fire was lessened enough - was a rushed, cramped affair. The washroom was far too small to fit everyone. Even worse, as was expected from a bunker running low on resources, they hadn't much to work with.

And the clock was ticking, as the General reminded everyone. The storage room doors wouldn't last much longer. Sure, the fire would take some time to spread through the level, but the smoke and vapours would spread quicker, and if more rooms caught fire… Sam shuddered at the thought.

Catra sliced off the sink and toilet, opening the pipes and turning the room into a fountain, and the General sent those who hadn't been splashed much with fuel in first so they could join Adora. That meant Glimmer, Bow, Daniel, Sha're - and Sam and Entrapta.

Sam hated leaving the others - she just knew the General would, given the chance, take too many risks for himself in order to keep others safer - but they had no choice.

They reached the lift, where Adora was guarding the closed doors. "Locked!" she called out.

Sam pressed her lips together. The Eurondans didn't have cameras in the bunker - as far as she could tell, another oversight perhaps, or the result of limited resources - but the electronic locks were linked. They couldn't just crack the doors open without the risk of alerting the Eurodans that they had survived the fire.

"We'll hack it," she said. Which might be easier said than done. The Eurondans weren't on the level of the Ancients, but their electronics were more advanced than Earth's native technology, and the system architecture was utterly alien.

Fortunately, she quickly discovered that this door worked like the storage room door that they had already hacked. That meant they already knew where the weak defences were. They still had to be careful, though, to avoid triggering an alert or lockdown, and checking took precious time. And they had to hack the lift as well, which was a challenge in itself.

But one Sam could handle.

Teal'c arrived, carrying Alar, followed by Lenkova. Shortly before they opened the lift's doors, Isa and Campbell joined them as well. That left…

"Where's Catra and Jack?" Adora asked, sounding tense.

"They are bringing up the rear," Isa reported.

Typical! Sam bit her lower lip. Then she froze. That sound… And did she feel the air moving, like a breeze? She checked her scanner. The temperature around the storage room was quickly rising - the doors must have failed! They were running out of time! And soon, air!

The General arrived at the nearest corner, running all out.

“Where’s Catra?” Adora yelled.

“She’s coming!” he replied. “She’s faster than I am.”

But the fire was spreading - the entire level was heating up. Sam could see it on her scanner as they piled into the lift.

Sam focused on removing the last defences of the system. And stopping the system from sounding an alert.

“Catra!” Adora yelled again.

But there she was! Sam looked up as the programs finished taking over the controls and saw her running towards them, on all fours, claws tearing up the floor.

And behind her, Sam could see flickering light illuminating the hallway - the fire was growing closer.

“Everyone aboard!” the General said. “Let’s go!”

Sam pushed a button, and the doors closed.

Then the lift started moving.

*****

Catra couldn’t help glancing at the floor of the cabin - or platform; it was a freight lift - for a moment. Below them, on the level they were leaving, the fire was spreading. Sooner or later, the flames would reach the lift shaft. They had to be out of the lift by then - and as far away from the shaft as possible. If that fire turned into

the thing from the Earth action movie in that skyscraper while they were in the shaft…

But there was nothing they could do about that. If only the lift were faster - Catra was sure most would be faster climbing a ladder. The more time this took, the more time the fire had to reach them - and the Eurodans above them time to get ready.

At least their group was ready. Adora had changed her sword into a shield again and was standing in the middle of the doors, ready to block enemy fire, and everyone else was lining up behind her, weapons aimed.

Or keeping their head down, in Entrapta's case.

The lift stopped with a soft beeping noise, and the doors started to open. A moment later, Catra's ears twitched as she heard several of the Eurondans' ray guns go off, and the door rang from the impacts - few, if any, hit the widening gap.

Amateurs, she thought. They had fired far too soon - and with weapons that couldn't penetrate the metal doors. Even Kyle would have done better than this.

Despite the shots, the doors kept sliding open, and more and more energy bolts were hitting Adora's shield. But that meant the enemies were exposing themselves as well. They were as skilled at taking cover as they were at other infantry tactics, and Catra saw Jack put two bullets into the head of a guard standing at a corner, not behind it, before the doors had opened wide enough for Adora to rush through.

As the Eurondan fell back, gun dropping to the ground, Isa rose, a shot bouncing off her armoured shoulder, and cut loose with the heavy machine gun.

A group of Eurondans was shredded by the bullets, bodies collapsing in pools of blood, parts blown off, as Isa swung her gun around, and Adora charged forward, Catra right behind her.

The Eurondans were breaking before Adora reached their line but were too slow to get away in time. Adora smashed into their front, shield out, and half a dozen Eurondans were thrown back, slamming against the wall with loud cracks. One tried to rally them, screaming something at the running guards, but they ignored him - and when he turned to shoot at Adora, Catra sliced through his arm and weapon with a swipe of her claws, and he dropped to his knees, staring at his bleeding stump as if he couldn't believe his eyes.

Whether he managed to stop the bleeding or not, he was out. Catra was rushing after Adora. "Next one left!" she yelled - according to Entrapta's projected map, the Stargate was about three potential choke points this way.

Adora smashed a few more too-slow guards into the wall - and the ceiling in one case - and whirled, moving her shield to block a ragged volley from a side tunnel.

"Fire in the hole!"

Catra gasped at Campbell's yell - and pressed her hands over her ears the moment a grenade shot between her and Adora, going off in the side tunnel. The explosion cleared the tunnel. Thoroughly.

They rushed on, through and past the wounded and the dead. They passed the first two potential chokepoints without any resistance - the Eurondans must have lost all cohesion. The third choke point, right before the gate room, was held by three guards.

Adora didn't even slow down for them. She charged through them and the doors in one smooth motion - and drew up to a sharp stop.

Catra sprinted after her, then veered off to the side as soon as she was in the gate room. What was…? Oh.

She stopped as well, her claws ripping the floor open, and glared at Tarlan, who was standing next to the D.H.D. - which was covered in blocks of explosive.

Damn.

*****

"Don't move, or I'll destroy the command console, and you will be stranded here!"

"It's actually called the D.H.D. - the Dial Home Device," Jack O'Neill said with far more nonchalance than he felt as he joined Adora and Catra in the gate room. If the fool blew up the D.H.D., they would be stuck on a foreign planet *again*. And one with far less friendly inhabitants than Etheria.

"I don't care what you call it. This is the device that controls the Stargate. Without it, you won't be able to flee," Tarlan yelled.

Jack wanted to just shoot the idiot and be on their way, but if the Eurondan had the detonator on a dead man's switch, that would be a terrible idea.

"Sir!" Carter had arrived.

Jack held up a hand. "Stand back, Carter! We don't want the nice Nazi to get nervous." More nervous, actually - the guy was already twitchier than a junkie going cold turkey. Too twitchy to bear more pressure - his eyes were already darting back and forth as he tried to keep Jack, Adora and Catra in his view. If they spread out, he might blow the D.H.D. up out of sheer desperation.

"Don't do it!" Adora said. "You gain nothing from destroying your last hope of surviving this!"

Tarlan clenched his teeth. "I heard what you told Alar - you want to destroy us!"

“We don’t have any quarrel with you,” Jack snapped. “We just want to go home.”

“You sabotaged the agreement that would have saved us!” Tarlan was panting and sweating now.

Teal’c arrived, Alar slung over his shoulder. And stunned, Jack noted with relief. The last thing they needed was Alar telling the idiot with the bomb to die for their cause or something. Although the Space Nazi Führer hadn’t seemed to be that willing to die. If he could be persuaded to order Tarlan to stand down… No, too risky - the rest of the Eurondans had had no qualms about sacrificing their leader to kill Jack’s friends.

“Look, you and your people need the D.H.D. more than we do. Without it, you won’t get any supplies - and can’t escape the bunker when your power runs out,” Jack said. “We can whip up a computer to control the Stargate with what we have with us.”

“Well, it wouldn’t be easy, or… Ow!” Entrapta piped up behind Jack, but Carter had that under control. Right now, honesty was the worst policy.

“You would die with us!”

“No, we would not.” Adora took a step forward, and Jack held his breath. “We would restore your planet’s magic, use that to cleanse the poison from the surface, and then leave this bunker.”

“And we’d grab the Stargate and build a control device while we wait for your enemies to wipe you out,” Catra added. “Or we construct an FTL communicator and contact our fleet to fetch us.”

“You wouldn’t survive!”

“We’ve survived worse,” Catra shot back.

Isa arrived. “The fire is spreading, sir,” she reported in a low voice. “It has gotten past the lift shaft.”

Jack saw Catra sniff the air and then clench her teeth. Time was running out. Maybe if he shot the guy's hand off… or if he hit the detonator… A dead man's switch was one thing, but Jack doubted that Tarlan had rigged the bomb to explode if the transmission cut off or something. Still risky, but better than dying in the bunker fire.

"We all can survive," Adora said. "You, us, your people. No one else has to die. We can end the war, restore your planet, and help you set up a country for your sleeping people."

"We'd rather die than lose our world!" Tarlan spat.

"You're about to do both," Catra said. "The fire's spreading - I can smell the smoke coming closer. How much longer until you lose the command centre? And then your enemies can finish you off, and even if we all die, they can work on restoring the surface - as you planned."

"Whether you destroy the D.H.D. or not, you can't win the war any more," Adora said. "But you can still save your people - if you let us help you."

Tarlan remained silent - but as tense as a bowstring. He was looking around wildly now - at the walls and the floor, not just at Jack's friends and himself. And at the Stargate.

Jack drew a short breath through his clenched teeth. He hated trying to make fanatics see reason. Especially desperate ones. "You can't take us with you. We can escape the bunker. Your people can't."

"You're stuck here as well!"

"No, we are not," Adora said. "We have magic and much more advanced technology. We can survive here. But your people cannot. Not without our help. Let us help you, please. No one else has to die." She smiled at Tarlan. "Think about your people. They depend on you. They trust you. Do you want them to die in their

sleep? From a fire your own men set? Or do you want them to live? In peace?”

Tarlan shook his head. He seemed to be crying. “We can’t live in peace with the Breeders! They want to wipe us out!”

And with good reason, Jack thought. But not even attempted genocide justified a genocide.

“We won’t let them kill you,” Adora said. “Trust us. We can stop the war - we will stop the war. If you let us. We just want to help you.”

Tarlan blinked - he was crying. “But…”

“Please.”

Tarlan closed his eyes, and Jack held his breath.

A moment later, the detonator dropped to the floor, and Tarlan collapsed, sobbing.

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Tense Negotiations Part 1

Underground Base, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Yes! Tralan had dropped the detonator. Adora beamed, relieved - he had seen reason! They could save this work without further deaths!

Jack was moving towards the D.H.D., and Catra had already snatched up the remote detonator and was handing it over to Entrapta, but Adora walked to the sobbing Tralan and crouched down to gently pat his shoulder. "We'll save your people," she promised.

"From themselves as well," Catra muttered before joining Jack in removing explosives from the D.H.D.

"Uh… speaking of saving people…"

Adora turned to look at Bow.

He grimaced. "We need to stop that fire. Or contain it."

"Yes!" Entrapta chimed in. "The scanner shows it's spreading on this level - and if it reaches this room, we won't be able to move in supplies or evacuate anyone. Not unless they're fire-proof."

"And if the defence shield goes down, the bunker will likely be bombed by the Eurondan Alliance," Sam added. "The fire's already covering a third of this level. Although no essential areas have been touched yet, the air quality is dropping - the filters must be straining."

Adora heard Tralan gasp. "No!"

She shook her head. "Alright. We have to stop the fire from spreading any further."

“And the rest of the Eurondans from shooting at us,” Catra added.

Right. Tralan wasn’t their leader. And Alar was still stunned.

“We’ve got enough explosives here to put out an oil well fire,” Jack commented. “Just saying.”

Tralan gasped again, and Adora frowned at Jack. Sometimes, like now, his jokes were a bit disturbing. At least she hoped that he was joking. “No explosives,” she said. “We’ll get Mermista. And Frosta.”

“Oh! Good idea!” Entrapta nodded. “I thought about modifying some of my bots to shoot fire suppressants, but that would probably have taken too long.”

“That still doesn’t solve the problem with everyone else shooting at us,” Jack said.

“Glimmer, please open a Stargate and get Mermista and Frosta,” Adora said, rising. “We’ll deal with the Eurondans in the meantime.”

Glimmer opened her mouth, and Adora half-expected her to say that she was needed here, but after a moment, her friend nodded. “Right.” She turned to Sam and Entrapta. “Dial to the forward base.”

Adora was tempted to tell them to dial straight to Etheria - that would be faster; they still had to fetch Mermista and Frosta to the Stargate - but she knew the procedure. They wouldn’t expose Etheria’s address like that.

While the Stargate started dialling, Adora walked back to the gate room’s door. Catra joined her.

“I can smell the smoke through the mask,” she said. “We don’t have much time left.”

Adora pressed her lips together and lifted her mask for a quick check - the air was getting worse indeed. They would have to contain the fire somehow, and quickly. But they couldn't do that with the Eurondans shooting at them. Or, they could, but it would make everything more difficult and cause more deaths.

She couldn't see anyone in the hallway. Were they already fighting the fire? That would make sense - they couldn't stand up to Adora and her friends, and the fire was a much more dangerous threat. But the Eurondans hadn't struck her as very sensible. Not at all, actually - they set fire to their own bunker, after poisoning the entire planet, and both times to defeat an enemy? That was suicidally stupid!

Well, it was time to talk some sense into them. "Can you tap into their communications?" Adora asked, looking back at Entrapta. The Stargate was collapsing - Glimmer and Bow had just left.

"Can we? We already did!" Entrapta smiled. "Though they aren't saying anything interesting. It's mostly calls for help and complaints about cowardice."

"Alright. I need to talk to their leader. Their new leader," Adora said.

"Whoever that is," Catra said, looking down the hallway. "And we need to ensure that they don't set this room on fire as well."

"Isa, Campbell - secure the checkpoint!" Jack snapped behind them. "Lenkova, secure the explosives. Carter, plug those air vents or something!"

"Yes, sir!"

"Yes, General!"

"Yes, sir."

That was handled. Adora smiled and grabbed her communicator. She cleared her throat, then switched to the channel already

highlighted by Entrapta. “This is She-Ra calling the leader currently in charge of the Eurondans. We have control of this planet’s Stargate. The fire you set hasn’t hurt any of us, nor Alar, which we took prisoner. But it’s spreading and will soon reach critical parts of your installation. We want to save you before it’s too late, but we can’t do that with you fighting us.”

Well, they probably could, but it was better for everyone if the Eurondans stopped fighting right now.

“How did you get on this channel?” a young voice asked.

“Laren! That’s not the point!” another voice, slightly older-sounding, added. “And don’t give them any information!”

Adora sighed. “This is She-Ra. I want to talk with your leader. If we don’t do something soon, you’re doomed. There has been enough loss of life - and all of it on your side. Let’s end this.”

“Really?” Catra stared at her.

Adora winced. That probably hadn’t been the best way to word this.

*****

“Alright! This is like dealing with a lab fire. Just a lot bigger. And we don’t have a lab with automated fire-fighting systems, nor do we have bots ready to step in. And we can’t just evacuate the place and let the fire burn itself out. OK, it’s not like dealing with a lab fire at all.”

Despite the situation - and the correct, if not very encouraging summary - Samantha Carter had to smile at Entrapta’s comment. “We might still have to evacuate the Eurondans, even if we manage to get the fire under control,” she pointed out. “If the reactors or their command centre are lost to the flames, the Eurondan Alliance will likely exploit this and launch strikes on this facility.” It might take them a while to realise it wasn’t a trap, though Sam was pretty sure it wouldn’t take them longer than it

would take to replace a reactor - or a command centre. Although if they just had to build an adapter and could connect a mobile power generator… it depended on the power demands of the Eurondans.

"Also, we can't seal off the burning areas and pump the air out," Entrapta added. "Or they would have done that already. Their construction isn't very optimised. We had better bunkers in the Horde."

Sam was happy that the Eurondans hadn't thought to add such features - they would have used them against Sam's friends and herself. "Sealing off the burning sections will still help. It will at least slow down the fire," she said, "even if it might not stop it."

"OK! Let's do that then!"

"Once Adora gives the go-ahead," Sam said. Adora was still negotiating with the Eurondans. Judging by her grimace, things were not going too well. "The Eurondans have to agree to stop fighting us."

Entrapta blinked. "But why wouldn't they? If they keep fighting, they'll lose the facility. They can't fight us and the fire. It's not logical."

The Eurondans hadn't acted very logically at all, in Sam's opinion. 'Suicidal' would be a more precise term. Although Tralan - who was begging the others over the comm channel to stop fighting - showed that some of them retained a modicum of common sense. Or the ability to face facts, even if they had to be shoved in their faces by a magical princess breaking through your entire force. "I think they'll see reason," she told her friends. Eventually, at least. "So, what can we do to seal off the burning areas?"

"We can't use their defence field - since the fire is spreading, it must not repel heat," Entrapta said. "That's actually an interesting weakness, though you can probably compensate by adding enough insulation, space or just armour around your projector

and shield generator to avoid it catching fire. Anyway! The doors should be able to withstand the flames for some time - long enough for Mermista and Frosta to arrive - but I think the air ducts are the problem."

"I concur." Though Adora and the others smashing their way through all doors, the fire hot on their heels, couldn't have helped. "And the ventilation system is likely supplying the fire with fresh oxygen. We need to cut that." Taking out the entire ventilation system would doom the facility, with the surface and atmosphere poisoned.

"Alright - let's check the air duct layout!" Entrapta pushed a few buttons, and a holographic projection of the facility - as far as they had managed to scan it - appeared between them and Adora, who was now gesturing wildly with one hand as she glared at the communicator in her other hand.

Sam focused on the air vents. "I see the problem," she said, wincing.

"Lots of redundancy," Entrapta said. "We'll have to seal off… these, these, and these air ducts. But only if we can manage that in the next ten minutes. Or this area there will be lost as well."

Sam nodded. "And if that area starts burning, this area could be cut off." She pointed at a large section of the floor below them.

"That's… the infirmary and part of their quarters," Entrapta said after checking their scanner's result.

Sam nodded. "We might have to evacuate them soon."

And if the fire took this area, then two of the stasis vaults would be in danger next.

"Let's prepare to seal the air ducts," Entrapta said. "I think we'll have to use armour plate for that. And sealing those will be tricky."

Sam winced again. “We could ferry special equipment from Earth,” she said, “but that would take too long.”

“Bow’s trick arrows!” Entrapta perked up. “They could seal the most crucial air ducts!” She blinked. “But he left with Glimmer.”

Sam wanted to curse. That would have been a solution. Although… “We won’t have time to whip up a reagent from the available resources here,” she said. “We’ll have to go with the armour plate, but getting that seal tight enough will be difficult. Cutting armour plate so it fit an air duct and sealed it was nigh impossible on the fly. Or in time.

“The Eurondans should have some industrial glue,” Entrapta said. “And I think I know how we can jam the armour plate into the ducts.”

She was looking at Adora, Sam realised. Oh. Of course.

*****

“...no, we don’t have the time to wait until you can discuss this further with your officers! *You* don’t have the time - the fire’s spreading as we speak! And we can’t stop it while you’re still trying to fight us - we’d have to take your forces out first! So stop being stupid and agree to stop attacking us so we can save you!”

Catra shook her head as Adora tried again to make the Eurondans see reason. Her ears twitched as she listened to the Eurondan’s answer.

“We can’t trust you! You’re as bad as the Breeders!”

“*We* aren’t trying to kill you all!” Adora retorted. “We’re trying to save you!”

Catra couldn’t resist. She rose on the tips of her toes, bent towards the communicator Adora was holding and added: “And you started the war with the Eurondan Alliance.”

"They were about to destroy us!"

Adora glared at her, of course.

Catra shrugged. "Can't let them forget that," she said. If those idiots would rather doom their entire people than stop the war and accept help, then it might probably be better to wipe out their leaders.

"That was then, this is now," Adora said through clenched teeth. "You're both fighting over a ruined world - and you're losing. We're offering you a way out of this."

"We won't abandon our home world! It's ours by right!"

Catra shook her head and sighed.

Adora rolled her eyes for a moment and took a deep breath to calm down. "No one says you have to abandon your world. I - we - can restore your world. But you need to stop fighting us."

"We're only defending ourselves!"

The man was technically correct, Catra had to admit - the Eurondans were holed up at several choke points and not attacking the gate room any more. They had learned that, at least.

"You are letting the fire spread. Soon, it will become uncontrollable," Adora said.

"We're fighting the fire."

Catra looked at Entrapta and Sam. "Is the fire still spreading?" she asked. According to her nose, it was, but her friends had their magitech scanner.

"Uh… yes," Entrapta replied. "Although it slowed down a little for a while, it's spreading as fast as at the start again."

“Did you hear that?” Adora asked. Without waiting for an answer, she added: “Whatever you’re doing is not enough. We’re running out of time, so this is our last offer: Stop fighting us, withdraw your forces, or we’ll have to take them out so we can save the rest of your people! We won’t let your pride destroy your people!”

“If we have to destroy you to save you, we will,” Catra heard Jack whisper under his breath and chuckled.

“Please, Kaltur. We cannot stand against them. We cannot hurt them. The longer we try, the worse we suffer,” Tralan added on the comm.

“I won’t listen to someone who got taken prisoner. Or worse.”

Catra looked at Alar, who was still on the floor, stunned. “I guess that means their leader is now their former leader.”

“This wouldn’t happen if this were a kingdom,” Adora muttered. Louder, she said: “Then ask your surviving troops, those who have faced us. You have no chance. The longer you refuse to accept that, the worse your situation will become - if you wait too long, you’ll have to evacuate the entire facility. And not because of us but because it will be a burned-out husk!”

Catra sighed, shaking her head. “If they won’t listen, we’ll have to take out their troops.” That might actually make it easier to stop the war. If the Eurondans had no forces left, they couldn’t fight on. Though after listening to the negotiations, she wasn’t sure if even that would be enough for the Eurondans or if they’d try to mobilise everyone else and send them out as cannon fodder or something. According to her research, a few Earth kingdoms had done that in past wars.

“Please,” she heard Adora whisper with a grimace. She hated this, Catra knew.

Catra clenched her teeth. If they had to take the Eurondans out to save them, she’d personally take care of Kaltur. A leader who

would rather sacrifice their people than their pride couldn't be tolerated.

Kaltur still hadn't answered. During the whole discussion, he had been quick to reply. Was this a good sign? She leaned closer, but her ears weren't picking up anything; they must have closed the channel.

Or they might want to leave them hanging to gain more time or something. Catra eyed the hallway leading to the 'frontline'. Were they preparing more traps? Even after their arson backfired like that?

"We're withdrawing our troops."

"Thank you!" Adora replied, smiling.

That meant they couldn't rely on help from the Eurondan troops to fight the fire. Catra didn't mind, though - she wouldn't trust them anyway.

"Alright! As soon as they have withdrawn, we'll move in," Adora told Kaltur.

"And after we have run a scan for traps," Catra added.

Once burned, twice shy or something like that.

*****

Jack O'Neill couldn't help looking over his shoulder as he followed Adora, Catra, Carter and Entrapta to the evacuated area closest to the fire. He didn't trust the Eurondans. They might have agreed to stop the fighting and withdraw their troops from the area, but that didn't mean they had surrendered. Or agreed to make peace. It was a truce at best, in his opinion. And truces could be and were broken all the time, as soon as it was convenient for someone. Worse, Euronda wasn't Earth, where you needed at least an excuse to break a truce or you might be out of luck the next time you wanted a truce - and you might get some stern looks thrown

your way by the United Nations, but that didn't really matter. The Eurondans had no reason to care for any supposed damage to their reputation. Their local enemies already hated them - attempted genocide tended to get that reaction - and the Alliance wasn't going to let them continue their war of extermination either.

So, as soon as the fire was contained, or looked contained, the Space Nazis would try to double-cross them. Maybe even earlier, if they had a death wish and decided that killing their enemies was more important than surviving; they certainly seemed to have thought so when they started the fire. Or they had been too arrogant or stupid to consider the consequences. That kind of fanaticism, arrogance and stupidity fit the Nazis perfectly.

"Please, save my people!"

Alar, dragged along by Teal'c, on the other hand, was now veering hard into playing the victim. Also something many Nazis had done.

"We're doing what we can," Adoa told him.

"And we'd already be done if you had stopped fighting us sooner," Catra added.

"That was Kaltur's ill-advised decision," Alar said. "There will be consequences for his shortsighted attempt to usurp my leadership."

Jack rolled his eyes. If Alar expected that the Alliance would put him in charge of the Eurondans so he could take revenge on his former underlings who had decided that he was an acceptable sacrifice, he would be disappointed. Probably - the Alliance might not intervene if Alar managed to get back into power since Kaltur had managed to thoroughly annoy even Adora, but the princesses weren't exactly fans of purges and bloody revenge.

"We have to focus on fighting the fire, not revenge," Adora told him.

"Of course!"

Jack rolled his eyes at Alar's toadying up. We should have left him back in the gate room with the others, he thought. But his knowledge of the bunker might be useful, and so they had dragged him along.

"And here's the storage room we need!" Entrapta announced. "We can get the armour plates here! And the glue we need as a sealant. It's too bad that you don't use this particular heat-resistant glue for everything - we would have more than enough to seal off all ducts!"

"It's an essential part for constructing new aero-fighters, and our supplies are limited, so we can't spare any of it for other tasks," Alar said.

They had been waging their world war on a shoestring budget, hadn't they? Jack thought.

"Well, you won't need more aero-fighters," Adora said as she grabbed a stack of armour plates. "That the right size?"

"Yes. Well, larger than we need, but that's better than too small," Entrapta replied.

"Adora can make everything fit," Catra added. "Brute force for the win."

Adora pouted at that. "Let's go. The fire's spreading as we talk."

"We should have enough time to get the planned fire barriers up," Carter said.

"Let's hurry anyway," Catra added. "I can smell the smoke growing worse through the mask."

They double-timed it out of the storage room, Adora leaving two cracks in the door as she manhandled the armour plates through it, and continued toward the fire.

“Are the Eurondans holding their positions?” Jack asked Carter as they approached their goal.

“Yes, sir. I am constantly tracking them,” she told him.

“Good.” Between her magic scanner and Catra’s ears, they probably were safe enough to pull this off.

Jack would still be on his guard. It wasn’t as if he had anything else to do here than watch out for his friends, anyway - he wasn’t a firefighter. Nor could he lift a piece of armour plate over his head like Adora was doing.

“Good! Now bend it a little and push it in!” Entrapta told her. “Not too much, so it fits snugly.”

Adora grunted a little as she bent the plate, then stuffed it into the air duct opening - without bothering to remove the grate there first. Jack winced at the sound of screeching metal and crumbling concrete-like material.

“Great! Now, let’s seal it up!” Entrapta’s hair tendrils wielded two glue dispensers and went to work. A few seconds later, they withdrew. “Done! Off to the next one - we’ve got all the air ducts we need to seal marked down.”

“And then my people will be safe!” Alar said.

“Well, safe for the moment,” Entrapta corrected him as they rushed out again. “Given enough time, the fire will spread anyway as the heat breaks down the glue - though I think your doors will fail first if our material analysis is correct. And it should be unless our scanners were malfunctioning, which I don’t think they did.”

“What?” Alar gasped and stumbled, Teal’c carrying him more than dragging him for a few steps. “But…”

“They will hold long enough for our friends to arrive and put out the fire,” Carter told Alar as they entered the next room.

“Now be quiet, we’re working,” Catra added.

Alar fell silent. Following orders was another trait of Nazis, Jack reminded himself, though he couldn’t tell yet if that was a good thing or not in this case.

*****

“And here we are! On foreign shores, to save the day!” Sea Hawk raised his fist to the ceiling as soon as he had stepped through the portal.

“Ugh. It’s not a shore - Glimmer told us explicitly that this base has no access to the ocean. Or any large body of water.” Mermista scowled at him, then looked around.

“My dear Mermista! It’s the principle of the thing - the symbolism!”

Adora felt relief filling her as Glimmer, Bow and Frosta followed the two down the ramp. Her friends had arrived just in time. Not that she had really doubted them, of course. “Hello!”

“Welcome to Euronda,” Catra drawled behind her.

“Hello.” Mermista nodded at them. She was carrying her trident. “Glimmer said you needed us urgently.”

“Where is the fire?” Frosta cracked her knuckles.

“This way!” Entrapta’s hair pointed towards the door. “And then all the way down the hallway. Oh, and you should wear masks - the air in the burning areas is really bad.” She blinked. “But you need to wait until Adora restores magic to the planet, or you can’t really do much.”

“You haven’t done it yet?” Frosta asked, then looked at her hands, flexing her fingers. Probably trying to use her power.

Adora shook her head. “You were told about the situation here?”

“Yes,” Mermista said, frowning. “Those people here poisoned their entire world to kill everyone else because they wouldn’t submit to their rule. And now they are not only losing the war they started but also in danger of dying to the fire they started to kill you.” She rolled her eyes. “And we’re going to save them anyway. Ugh.”

She didn’t mean it, Adora knew. Mermista was just a little… snarky about such things. She would do the right thing even if she complained about it. Adora was a little more concerned about Frosta. But only a little. Both were here, after all. Adora nodded. “Yes.”

“Even if we have to crush them for that,” Catra added with a smirk.

“Anyway,” Adora went on. “Since we need to return magic to the planet and we also have to purge the poison, it’d be best to do that on the surface so I can, ah, use the magic surge for that, but the Eurondans aren’t cooperating.”

“They don’t believe in magic,” Entrapta added. “They think this is a ploy to discover their aero-fighter bays, even though we already know where those are thanks to our scans.” She pouted. “We showed them the data, but they still didn’t believe us.”

“Charming fellows,” Jack said. “They must be the life of any party.”

“Anyway,” Adora repeated herself. “So, we have to do it here.” And she would have to channel the magic to the surface blindly.

“Just don’t turn the bunker into a plant,” Jack told her.

“Sir!”

“She’s only done that once,” Entrapta said. “So, it’s not really likely.”

“Don’t give her ideas.”

“Let her focus!”

Adora closed her eyes and raised her sword above her head. This was it. She had done this before. Just focus and release the magic. Reach out and do it. She could feel… there!

She concentrated on the familiar feeling of the blockage. Visualised it.

And cut it.

Once again, she felt the magic surge, into and through her, filling her with power. Urging her to release it uncontrollably, on a whim.

She gritted her teeth and fought the urge, even if she felt as if she was about to burst. She would use this power, not waste it! Heal this world.

At the mere thought of healing, the magic reacted, pushing against her, trying to reach out to the others in the room - in the bunkers, seeking wounds and sicknesses.

Once again, Adora held back, groaning with the effort. The pressure was growing stronger, straining her even more. Demanding to be released. But she had to heal the world, not the people here. She opened her eyes and stared at the ceiling. Above her, five hundred yards above her, was the surface. Poisoned. Dead. She couldn't see it, not directly, but she had seen the images on Entrapta's scanner.

She focused on those pictures. The memory of the wasteland above. Imagined the poison seeped into the soil. Drifting through the air. Polluting the world.

And poured magic into it. Through her sword. Through herself.

For a moment, it almost felt as if the magic was cheering as it flowed through her, surged upwards, pushing through metal, stone and earth to reach the surface, then bursting forth like a giant fountain, magic spreading through soil and air.

Purging. Healing. Restoring. Seeding.

Spreading.

On and on it went. Healing. Restoring. Purging. Seeding.

Adora trembled. Panted with the effort. Grunted with the strain and pain of channelling a world's magic far longer than she had before. Guiding it to cover the entire world. Heal the world. Restore it. Purge the poison. She couldn't give in. She couldn't release the power. Not before she was done. It was too important. She had to keep going. Let the magic spread. Cover the entire world.

But she felt the magic slipping from her control. Her focus weakening. Her body shaking.

And then she felt herself falling.

*****

"Adora!"

Samantha Carter gasped when she heard Catra scream and saw Adora collapse. All that magic, all that power, channelled through her, through her dropping sword… Sam threw herself to the ground.

"Adora!"

"Take cover!"

"No!"

Sam clenched her teeth as the room was filled with blinding light and deafening noise, drowning out the screams from the others as She-Ra's magic ran out of control. She should have taken precautions - taken shelter somewhere else instead of staying at ground zero. She closed her eyes. They would all die. Or worse. And just because she had been too stupid to take basic precautions. Stupid. Stupid. Stupid!

The noise cut off. She opened her eyes a tiny little bit, squinting. And wasn't blinded by magic.

"Anyone dead? Sound off if you're dead!"

The General! He was alive!

Sam raised her head and looked around. The General was just getting up.

"You idiot!" Catra was kneeling on the floor, Adora in her arms. "You idiot!"

"Whoa! Half my sensors are fried - Adora released so much magic, the sensors couldn't withstand it! We completely underestimated the stress from prolonged channelling of magic on that scale! Note to myself: Upgrade sensors!"

Entrapta was obviously fine, Sam noted.

"Ugh."

"What a harrowing *Adventure*!"

Mermista and Sea Hawk were fine as well.

Sam turned and checked the rest of the room. The Stargate was fine - as was the D.H.D. It looked like the magic surge had…

She blinked and brushed some hair from her face.

…completely vaporised the ceiling. And everything above it - she could see the sky above them. She-Ra's magic had created a huge shaft reaching the surface. No - a huge *crater*. Sam shivered. If that had happened with the sword pointed in their direction…

"Adora?" Glimmer asked.

"The idiot's still alive. But exhausted."

“Are you sure?” Bow looked concerned. Sam felt concerned as well.

“She hasn’t transformed back. And I know how exhaustion looks on her,” Catra replied.

“Oh.”

Right. Sam nodded and didn’t think about the implications. There were more important things to focus on.

“Oh! Let’s check the surface! And the atmosphere!” Entrapta beamed.

“Check for poison,” Glimmer added. “And keep your masks on!”

Sam quickly picked up her scanner and had to scroll through several notifications about damaged systems. The magic sensors were out. That was… not ideal, given that they were now exposed to the planet’s atmosphere.

But the working sensors didn’t detect any of the poison they had scanned before. “It seems that Adora managed to clean at least our immediate surroundings of the poison,” she reported, turning to the General. Who was, she noted, staring at her. “Sir?”

“Carter? That haircut isn’t regulation.”

She froze for a moment, then reached up to her head. And then behind her back.

Her hair had grown. A lot. It now reached down to the small of her back.

“Oh! That must have been a side-effect of the magic used to restore the surface. Or maybe a stray strand when Adora fell unconscious,” Entrapta said, cocking her head as she ran a scanner over Sam’s head. “Can you manipulate it?”

“No,” Sam replied.

“Too bad! We could’ve been hair buddies. Hair science lab buddies.”

For a moment, Sam didn’t know if she should be happy or disappointed. She settled for being happy.

“So… anyone else got some rapid hair growth? Or some additional limbs? Or got turned into a plant?” the General asked.

“Jack!”

“Just asking. Magic is unpredictable.”

Sam clenched her teeth again and quickly and discreetly checked herself. She should have noticed any change to her body, but she had missed her hair growing, and with magic on such a scale, anything was possible. Relieved, she confirmed that she didn’t have any appendages that she hadn’t had her whole life.

But she would get a thorough medical scan as soon as they were back on Earth. Just to make sure she hadn’t suffered any less obvious change.

“No change here… I think.”

“Not here either.”

“As far as I can tell, I am fine.”

“I can scan you!”

“You’ve doomed us all!”

What? Sam turned. Alar was staring at the sky, pale and shaking. Tralan didn’t look any better, Sam noted.

“Oh, don’t worry - the air and ground above us are safe. I will need some larger sensors - probably hooked up to Emily, once she arrives - to check how much of the planet was affected, but I think we’re pretty safe from contamination - Adora channelled the

magic for a long time. Relatively, of course," Entrapta tried to reassure them.

"No! We're doomed!" Alar retorted, shaking his head - and crying. "The Breeders will not miss this - our base is completely open!"

"You still got your fancy defence field," the General said.

"No." Alar sank to his knees. "There were at least three projectors above us… the field won't be able to last like this. We're doomed!"

Right. The Eurondans were at war. A war fought in the air. And they just created the perfect bomb trap right at the planet's Stargate. While a fire was still raging inside the facility, drawing resources and threatening their military facilities.

"Oops!" the General said, and Sam winced.

*****

Catra was going to kill Adora. After she made sure her love was alright. To exhaust herself like that, channelling enough magic to fry… a small fleet, probably. She glanced up at the sky visible above them. Clearly and easily visible thanks to the crater Adora's magic had created.

Then she looked at Adora. She was limp, laid across Catra's lap, eyes closed, mouth half-open, breathing steadily.

"You idiot," Catra whispered, pulling her closer for a quick, squeezing hug. As much of a squeezing hug as she could manage with Adora still being She-Ra. That, at least, was a good thing - if Adora had really hurt herself, she would have changed back, wouldn't she?

Catra didn't want to know. She just wanted her love to wake up so she could properly scream at her for being stupid.

"You've doomed us all!"

And she wanted to claw Alar's face off to stop him from whimpering and crying. But she would have to drop Adora for that. And her friends wouldn't like Catra killing a prisoner.

So she turned her head instead and spat: "Shut up! You aren't doomed. You just lost the war - but you were losing it anyway!" Really, as if he was the first leader of an evil horde finding themselves in the ruins of their headquarters with the enemy at their gates! Catra knew exactly how that felt, and she hadn't been such a whimpering mess when it had happened to her.

"But he's right - if the Eurondan Alliance forces know what they are doing, they'll spot this little hole quickly and will attempt to capitalise on the opportunity to finish off their enemy for good," Jack said. "And this is one nice bomb trap - even some old World War 2 bombers couldn't miss such a target."

"We're doomed!"

Someone shut him up!

"Although unless they already have a force close by in the air which they can reroute on the fly, we have some time left to fix this. Somehow," Jack went on.

"But… they surely will notice that the poison's gone? And attempt to investigate first?" Daniel said.

"They have been fighting for their lives for decades," Glimmer told him. "I don't think we can count on them stopping their attacks to investigate what they might assume was a reactor blowing up in this base or something. They won't want to give their enemies time to fix things."

Catra nodded. She wouldn't do that either in their place.

"And they might not even notice that the poison is gone," Entrapta added. "If their sensors are not significantly better than the Eurondans', and I don't think they are, or the air battle would probably have been won by them much earlier thanks to superior

sensor ranges, they can't detect poison from afar - or its absence."

Right. Catra looked up. The fact that the crater was perfectly spherical might catch the attention of a scientist, but a military pilot would just see an opportunity. And speaking of the crater… She narrowed her eyes. "How stable are the crater walls?" she asked. If the walls started coming down, the Stargate - and anyone around it - would be buried under tons of stone and earth.

"Good question!" Entrapta beamed and looked at her tool. "Oh."

"The crater's surface wasn't hardened in any way, as far as we can tell," Sam reported.

"That means?" Jack asked.

"The top parts will start to crumble very soon, and the material sliding down into the crater might destabilise some of the material forming the lower parts, sir."

Uh-oh.

"Creating the world's worst landslide. Great." Jack shook his head.

"And it's starting!" Catra hissed - she could see the crater's surface moving. Dirt was starting to loosen and roll down the crater. Taking more dirt with it.

"That's… Something's moving inside the crater walls!" Sam exclaimed.

"What?"

"Yes - the entire wall is… on top of the surface as well," Entrapta confirmed. "That's… Oh."

Green spots appeared above them, rapidly spreading across the bare earth and stone walls.

Green plants, Cara realised. Growing through the walls, covering them. She almost checked if they had taken Perfuma with them - this looked like her going all out. But this was Adora's doing. Shaking her head, Catra smiled at her love. "Showing up the other princesses, huh?"

A clump of Earth hit the ground nearby, followed by another. And more, smaller specks fell down.

"Sir. While the plants are stabilising the crater walls, their rapid growth has shaken loose a lot of material," Sam said. "And it's all coming down."

"And She-Ra can't plug the hole because she's still out," Jack summed up. "Well, we…"

"...don't need She-Ra." Frosta raised her arms, and a pillar of ice rose in the middle of the room, covering the hole. Grinning smugly, she announced: "Problem solved!"

"Until it melts," Catra said, earning her a scowl.

"I'll just maintain it!"

"And, speaking of melting ice… don't we have a fire to fight?" Mermista said.

"Right." Glimmer nodded. "Follow me. Both of you."

Catra watched them leave. Between Frosta and Mermista, they should have the fire covered. And the ice here would hold long enough for the princess to get back and fix it. The sight of that had shut up Alar, too - the man was staring at the ice as if he had gone crazy. Crazier. Probably the straw to break his back after Adora's display. And the Eurondan Alliance might not have advanced sensors, but they wouldn't miss the plants growing in the crater. That should keep them from bombing it.

Should. Catra wasn't entirely sure she could trust anyone on this planet to have a little bit of common sense left. "We better contact the Eurondan Alliance," she said. "And quickly. We can't wait until Adora wakes up."

"Yeah," Jack agreed. "Daniel? How do you feel about arranging a truce between two blood enemies?"

Daniel winced. "Ah… I'll see what I can do?"

*****

Tense Negotiations Part 2

Underground Base, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"No pressure," Jack O'Neill told Daniel. "You just have to get them to put the war on hold for a while so we can let the diplomats hammer out some armistice."

Judging by the way Daniel frowned at him - mirrored by Sha're - Daniel didn't really feel reassured. "I have to get people who have been fighting for their very lives for decades to stop the war right when they are about to win."

"Yep." Jack shrugged with far more nonchalance than he felt. "Maybe focus on the fact that the Eurondans are already beaten?"

"I'll have to get them to listen to us first. Convince them we're not the Eurondans - or their allies," Daniel retorted. He turned to Carter. "Can we communicate with the Eurondan Alliance?"

"We are tapping into their communications," Carter replied. "Their encryption is not as good as the Eurondan's, but they seem to have compartmentalised their communications."

"We've hacked their aeroplanes' comms, but we're still working on the link to their headquarters," Entrapta added. "Their planes are headed this way, by the way. They probably saw the magic surge and want to investigate."

"Or they noticed that the Eurondans' defences are in shambles and want to exploit that," Jack pointed out. He looked up at the ice shield sealing off the big-ass hole in the ceiling. "I don't think that's bomb-proof."

Daniel nodded. "Alright. Let's hope the plants give them pause." He didn't sound very optimistic.

“Here! We put their aeroplane network on channel two!” Entrapta’s hair tendrils handed a communicator to Daniel.

“Thank you.” He cleared his throat. “Eurondan Alliance forces! This is Daniel Jackson speaking. I am a representative of Earth and Etheria, two powers from outside this solar system. We have arrived in the Eurondan Nation through a Stargate to investigate an attack on us and have taken control of the Stargate the Eurondan Nation has been using. We would like to talk to your leader.”

“They’ve cracked our encryption!”

“Communications are compromised. Continue according to protocols!”

“Understood.”

“Uh…” Daniel winced and looked at Jack.

Jack sighed. It looked like the Eurondans - the Eurondan Nation - did enough hacking that the Eurondan Alliance had standard operating procedures for that. Which was kind of a problem right now. “I guess they aren’t changing course?”

“No, sir,” Carter reported. “They are still flying directly at our current position. At their current speed, the estimated time of arrival is five minutes.”

“Please. This is no joke. We are from the stars. We have defeated the Eurondan forces in their base and are currently securing the defence complex. We aren’t your enemies,” Daniel pleased. Please halt your attack for the moment, and let us talk to your leaders.”

Jack pressed his lips together. This wouldn’t work. After decades of war to the knife, the Alliance pilots wouldn’t stop but press the attack. He knew how pilots thought.

“We have restored plant life to the area and are taking measures to restore the biosphere of your planet. Please stop your attack

and let us talk."

Once they saw the plants, they might stop their attack. Might. They might not even notice the plants if they were focused on their sensors and instruments. Jack cursed under his breath. This wouldn't work. They needed something not even a pilot with target fixation could miss. Something to give anyone seeing it pause.

"Keep talking!" he snapped. "I'll get help!"

"What? Jack? Wait! What are you doing?"

Jack ignored him and switched channels on his radio. "Frosta? We need you back at the gate at once!"

"Frosta?" Sha're asked.

"We're busy fighting the fire!" Frosta sounded annoyed.

"Let Mermista take over for a while. We need you to stop the Eurondan Alliance from covering us in bombs!" Jack retorted. "Glimmer! Get Frosta back to us at once!"

"What? What did you do?" Glimmer cut in.

"Nothing. But the Alliance pilots won't stop," Jack replied. "We need her to make a sign even a blind man can't miss!"

"Oh!"

"What? Hey!"

In a shower of sparkles, Glimmer and the struggling Frosta appeared next to the Stargate.

"There you are!" Jack felt relieved. "Create the biggest ice sculpture you've ever done - right on top of us!"

Frosta stared at him with wide eyes. Then she grinned. "Alright! Glimmer, take us up to the surface!"

“Try not to kill off all plants!” Entrapta yelled.

“Bombs will kill them as well!” Jack yelled back.

Glimmer and Frosta disappeared in another cloud of sparkles.

Jack turned to Daniel. “Tell them to watch out for ice sculptures!”

“I’m not even sure if they are listening to me,” Daniel replied. But he did as asked.

“Now we can just hope for the best,” Jack said. “In case this doesn’t work…”

“Dialling to forward base, sir,” Carter anticipated his order.

“Good.”

Jack looked at the ice above them. It must have started to melt, but that wouldn’t be a concern for a while. Nothing Frosta and Mermista couldn’t handle. As long as his idea worked.

“What’s Frosta doing?” Catra asked behind him.

“Oh! Let me check with the scanner!” Entrapta replied. “I should be able to get good visuals of it…”

Jack looked over her shoulder. And blinked. That was…

“Did she just create a sculpture of herself the size of an iceberg?” Daniel asked.

“Yep,” Jack said.

“Almost the size of her ego, I bet,” Catra added with a smirk.

Behind them, the wormhole stabilised.

“It’s still growing,” Entrapta reported.

Well, the Eurondans wouldn't have to worry about water for a while, Jack thought.

"The Alliance Aeroplanes are slowing down."

It was working. Jack softly sighed.

*****

She had to keep channelling the magic. Purge the poison. Heal the land. Purge. Heal. Endure. She had to… She had failed!

Adora woke up with a gasp and sat up. Or tried to - a hand on her face stopped her.

"Don't!" Catra hissed at her. "You've been out for hours!"

Adora was in Catra's lap. Well, her head was. And they were…

"Actually, less than an hour - forty-one minutes, to be exact."

That was Entrapta's voice! Adora turned her head. Entrapta was sitting on the ground, beaming at her while her hair kept pressing buttons on her tool. They were in the Eurondan gate room. She could see Campbell guarding the gate at the D.H.D. But where were the others?

"Close enough." Catra scowled.

"Actually…"

"It doesn't matter," Catra interrupted Entrapta. "The idiot here almost got herself seriously hurt trying to save another world!"

Trying? "What happened? Did I fail?" Adora asked. She had failed - she knew it! "I tried to heal the world…"

"And you did purge the poison from most of the landmass we're on," Entrapta said.

"You also vaporised half of the Eurondan defence complex," Catra added.

"Fifteen per cent, actually."

"Oh." Adora blinked and looked at the ceiling. "Is that… ice?" It looked like ice. A huge patch of ice covering most of the ceiling. No, *replacing* most of the ceiling.

"Frosta plugged the hole. And then created an ice statue of herself the size of Bright Moon," Catra explained. Or not.

"She did what?" This time, Adora managed to sit up.

They explained. Properly, this time.

*****

"...and that's why Mermista had to move the water so the melting sculpture won't fill the crater with water - Frosta already had to reinforce the ice cover here, but the water pressure could make that worse. We really should repair the ceiling here, but we don't have the material to do that."

"We've created a new lake?" Adora asked. That was… OK, not as bad as turning a spaceship into a plant, but it wasn't very responsible. You didn't rearrange the geography of a foreign world like that!

"They're still working on that. But it won't be a big lake," Catra said. "Anyway, that's why Glimmer and the others are up top, trying to prepare a canal for the water before the ice melts."

"They are digging a canal? How?" Adora asked.

"More like blowing a canal," Catra said.

"Jack is using explosives to remove an obstacle between the crater's edge and a ravine."

That made more sense. “And what about the Eurondans?” Adora asked. “You managed to stop the war, you said.” Thanks to Frosta.

“The Eurondan Nation has a truce with us. The Eurondan Alliance hasn’t agreed to a ceasefire, but they have stopped trying to bomb us,” Catra said. “Daniel’s trying to get them to parlay, but they’re stubborn, and I think they don’t really believe we’re aliens even after they saw Frosta’s ego trip up top and you rejuvenating the continent.” She shrugged. “He’s still talking in the next room.”

Adora nodded. If the Eurodans were talking instead of shooting - or bombing - each other, then that was a good thing. Still… “I should talk to them.”

“*You* need to rest! You exhausted yourself - you exhausted *She-Ra*!” Catra snapped.

Adora winced. Even She-Ra’s power had limits. No, she had limits. If she had been ready for this… She got up. “I’m fine.”

Catra narrowed her eyes at her, and Adora half-expected her to try to trip her to claim she wasn’t fine, but her lover muttered something under her breath - probably ‘idiot’ - and got up as well. “Well, let’s tell Glimmer that you’re awake.” She used her communicator before Adora could stop her.

Glimmer appeared with Bow a second later. “Adora! What were you doing?”

“I am fine,” Adora told her friends while they hugged her. “Just a bit tired.”

“Exhausted,” Catra added.

“Well, you’re not hurt according to my scans,” Entrapta said. “Though I don’t have enough data about She-Ra’s power when restoring magic to a planet to be a hundred per cent sure. However, I could compare your hair growth when you change into

She-Ra to Sam's recent hair growth and conclusively prove that they aren't the same."

"Sam's what?"

"You made Sam's hair grow. A lot," Glimmer told her.

"It's not magical, though," Entrapta added with a pout. "That would have been nifty."

Adora suppressed a groan. What else had she done? And how could she fix things?

Well, first, she had to end the war. Then, she could tackle the rest of the problems.

*****

Surface above the Underground Base, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter was a physicist. Not a landscaper. Not that she would say that out loud and invite the General to make a Star Trek reference. She had some experience with demolitions, though not as much as the General himself. A combat engineer would be better here. But they didn't have a combat engineer to deal with what was effectively an iceberg on land, so it fell to her.

"That should do it!" The General sounded pleased. "The charges are set. Now, everyone, get back so we can blow this joint as soon as Carter gives the word!"

The others did move away from the patch of land that separated the base of the colossal ice sculpture Frosta had created - in her image, Sam couldn't help adding to herself - from the closest ravine. She used her scanner again. If the explosives weren't enough, they could probably have Adora dig now that she was awake. Or, as an alternative, have Mermista control the water to carve a deeper canal to the ravine, though that was not too practical.

Neither would be necessary if she did her job well enough, though.

"To stand on the surface again… It's a dream come true."

"Our world, restored. A paradise."

"I've only ever seen it from the air. I've been to other planets, of course, but… it's not the same."

"It isn't. This is our home. Our world."

Tralan and Alar's awed conversation behind her wasn't helping, though.

"To see rivara plants grow again… I've only ever seen them in pictures."

"We have seeds stocked in our vaults, but… It's incredible to see plants as far as we can see."

"And you have She-Ra to thank for this," the General added. "Without her, this would still be a poisoned wasteland."

"And we shall not waste her gift!" Tralan said.

Sam winced as she re-ran the last scans and recalculated the yield. That sounded… not quite as bad as Priest, but there was a touch of fervour in the man's voice that bordered on the religious. She hoped it wasn't the start of another branch of the Church of She-Ra; Adora wouldn't like it.

And it would complicate the peace negotiations they were still trying to start.

"Don't forget Entrapta, who's busy restoring your life support systems back down the hole," the General said.

Systems that had been partially wrecked by Adora's magic, Sam mentally added.

“Of course.” Alar didn’t sound very grateful about that. Then again, that was ‘merely’ engineering and repair work. Not the restoration of the world’s biosphere by magic.

Sam pushed the thoughts away. The calculations and scans were done, and nothing had changed. She looked at the General. “We should be good, sir.”

“Great, Carter.” His grin made him look twenty years younger. “Here we go!” He held up the remote detonator.

A moment later, the ground in the distance vanished in a cloud of smoke and dust. Sam saw various earth clumps and rocks hitting the ground around it - pretty much where she had predicted. That didn’t matter, though. What mattered was whether or not they had blown a big enough crater to reach the ravine.

And according to her scanner, they had. It wasn’t quite perfect - the section that had blown open was a bit smaller than calculated - but it would be enough to keep the Eurondan bunker from getting flooded by Frosta’s work.

“So, Carter?”

“It’s done, sir.”

“Huzzah!” Sea Hawk cheered.

“Looks like you don’t have to stay and keep the statue frozen, then,” Mermista told Frosta.

“Don’t blame me; Jack said to create a huge sculpture.”

“He didn’t tell you to create a huge statue of yourself.”

“Ice is ice and melts the same.”

Sam rose from where she had been sitting, the movement making her feel the unfamiliar weight of her hair as her new ponytail slapped against her back. Maybe she should just cut it off with her

knife? She could have it trimmed properly back home; according to all the scans they had done, it was normal hair. Magically grown, but not magical itself. Which was a relief.

But Glimmer wanted Castaspella to take a look at it 'before doing anything drastic', and even the general had agreed that they should get an expert's opinion before cutting it. 'You can't be too careful with magic, especially magic on this scale', he had put it. She could bear it until then. She might even take a picture before cutting it back to regulation length.

Sam grinned as she looked around. She-Ra's magic had turned the whole area into lush, green fields and hills. No wonder the Eurondans were impressed.

The General joined her. "So, that's one problem solved. Too bad we can't solve the diplomatic problems with explosives."

"I am sure that the Eurondan Alliance will agree to peace talks once they confirm the extent of the changes Adora has wrought," Sam pointed out.

"They still suspect a trap."

She frowned. "That makes no sense. How do they explain this?"

He shrugged. "They don't have an explanation. And that makes them more suspicious. But I'm sure Daniel will convince them."

Sam hoped he was right.

*****

Underground Base, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and yes, we are aliens - humans, but from other planets."

"A likely story."

“But a true one. And as you have already seen, we also have other species here with us.”

“Tricks. You cannot fool us so easily.”

Catra snorted. “So much for showing off me and Isa, huh?”

Daniel turned to pout at her. “I didn’t expect that to convince them that we’re aliens. Not by itself. But put together with the other evidence we can produce, it should convince them of the truth of our claims. Eventually.”

“‘Eventually’.” Catra snorted again. “Before or after we arrive with a fleet?”

“No fleet is on the way,” Adora cut in.

“Not yet.” Catra grinned. “It might be faster to send a fleet than talk sense into them.”

Daniel turned back to the communicator. “We can meet in person, and you can have medical personnel examine them.”

What? Catra frowned at him. Getting her examined by some weirdo medic from a backwater planet? “That’s a low blow!” she hissed.

Daniel ignored her, but Sha’re made a sound as if she was suppressing a giggle.

“A meeting would be the perfect occasion for an ambush.”

“They’re paranoid.” Catra shook her head. “Just send some expendable soldiers,” she said, loud enough to be picked up by the communicator.

“Catra!” Adora hissed.

“What?” Catra frowned at her. “They’re fighting a war. They’re sending out people to die with every sortie.” Unlike the Eurondan

nations' aero-fighters, the Eurondan Alliance's aeroplanes were not remote-controlled, as they had found out earlier.

"Every soldier is crucial for the war!"

"You've seen the ice sculpture we created - you've seen it as it was grown. You've seen the crater we blew into your enemies' base. Isn't that enough to at least meet with us to verify our claims before you attack us and risk similar repercussions?" Daniel pleaded. "If this were a trap, what would be the point?"

A different voice replied: *"To get us to lower our guard and then do to us what you did to our enemies so you can conquer us both!"*

That was… actually a new twist, Catra had to admit. Still paranoid, but it made sense in a warped way.

"If you think we want to conquer both you and your enemies, does that mean you accept that we aren't part of the Eurondan Nation trying to fool you?" Daniel asked.

"You could have couped the old leader in a brutal civil war. And now you're trying to deceive us before we finish you off."

"Well, that's not an entirely unreasonable assumption," Catra commented. "They know their enemies." A group that would set their own base on fire or wreck their own world to destroy their enemies wouldn't hesitate to attempt such a ploy. And they had been suspiciously quick to sacrifice their leader in the process.

"How could we do that in a meeting far away from either your or your enemies' base?" Daniel sounded exasperated. "You have seen how we restored life to your world. Do you really think that we would need to trick you if we can do that?"

"Then what do you want?" Another new voice. Older.

"We want to end the war," Adora spoke up. "Stop the dying. Restore your world. *Help you.*"

After a pause, the same voice asked: *"And why would you do that?"*

"Because it's the right thing to do," Adora replied.

"Because we have the power to help you, and you need help," Daniel added. "We're not here to conquer your world."

"But we could if we wanted to," Catra whispered. It would be easy - the Eurondans of both factions had spent decades underground. Even with the restored plant life on the continent, they would be hard-pressed to launch a guerilla campaign. And even if they managed that, the best they could do was hide in the new wilderness. The Alliance could easily take and hold any base, and they could detect and track down any base the Eurondans built anew. Sooner or later, the guerillas would run out of supplies to wage even a limited war.

"Catra!" Adora hissed.

"Just saying."

"That's not helping!"

"Nothing seems to be helping," Catra retorted.

"Some people mistake kindness for weakness and restraint for incapability," Sha're commented in a low voice. "If all the Eurondans have ever experienced for a generation is all-out war, they might not understand that we won't use our power as much as we could."

"And demonstrating our power will be seen as a threat," Adora added.

Catra snorted again. It *was* a threat. But maybe a threat was what was needed to get the Eurondans to agree to a meeting.

"What do you have to lose?" Daniel tried again. "Even if you don't trust us to honour a truce, at worst, you would lose a few

soldiers. And in exchange, you stand to gain more information about us."

The older voice replied again: *"And what do you have to lose? You do not seem to be concerned about potential treachery on our side."*

"No, we are not," Daniel said.

Take that however you want, Catra thought with a grin.

A few seconds passed.

"Very well. We agree to a meeting under truce."

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Restored Zone, Main Continent, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We should have brought a chopper," Jack O'Neill commented as they approached the location for the meeting. "Would've been faster." Certainly faster than the skiffs they had brought through the Stargate as transports. They had been driving for hours - technically flying, but it felt like driving since they had to stick so close to the ground.

"We couldn't have managed to get it up and running in time," Bow disagreed, glancing back from the helm of the skiff for a moment. "With all the preparations needed."

Jack grunted. He knew that - he had checked the facts himself. The gate was large enough to fit a transport chopper through, but the logistics for the trip would have been too much. They would have needed extra transports for the fuel - forget setting up in-air refuelling on a foreign planet without an air base!

"The skiffs will look both less aggressive and more impressive, Jack," Daniel argued. "The Eurondans have nothing like this."

"They don't have choppers either," Jack shot back.

"But they understand the principles. This, though… Magitech is new for them." Daniel smiled. "And the skiffs don't look like military craft."

Which was part of Jack's problem with them - he felt too exposed on the skiff. It was like riding a bus into battle. A strafing attack by an Alliance fighter would… well, the shield projectors would stop it, but Jack would still prefer something visible around him.

"We don't have any advanced transports that fit through the Stargate, sir. They weren't a priority." Carter sounded slightly reproachful. As if Jack had been the one to refuse that project!

He had wanted the things! They were perfect for special ops missions! But the Alliance Command had decided to focus on shuttles. Compared to the proposed 'Gate-capable Advanced Transports', shuttles could haul a lot more cargo or troops, could go much faster - all the way across a solar system - and were much tougher and better armed as well. The Alliance needed shuttles far more than they needed special transports. Especially since most of what the special transports could do could be done with ground or conventional air transports. Unless you needed a space-capable transport that could fit through a Stargate.

"I'll bring it up again," he said.

"Entrapta proposed to modify Death Gliders for the purpose," Carter added.

Jack winced. Those things were barely-decent fighters. To change them into transports… He shook his head.

"We're about to reach the meeting spot," Bow reported. "It doesn't look as if anyone else is present."

They only expected the Eurondan Alliance delegation. "Carter?"

"Linking to Entrapta's scanner… there is an unknown aircraft circling about five miles out, sir. Similar design as their bombers."

Was that a trap? A bomb attack on them? Emily's shield might not be able to withstand that, but the bot supposedly had enough AA-capability to shoot down bombs. But if it were, wouldn't the Eurondans have sent more craft?

In any case, the skiff Adora and the others were on was already setting down, followed by the one transporting Entrapta and Emily. That one wobbled a bit; it was slightly overloaded with the big bot.

"Alright. Let's get ready for diplomacy," Jack said as Bow set down their own skiff.

And find out if this is a trap, he added to himself as he grabbed the tent they had brought with them.

Five minutes later - they had just finished setting up the tent - Catra called out: "They're coming!"

"Yes. They are on a course towards us," Entrapta confirmed.

Jack stood - his back didn't protest at all! - and grabbed his binocs. Indeed, the other craft was coming in low and slow. Not a bombing run, then. It wasn't a big transport - not even close to a C-130. Maybe as big as a C-47. And probably as capable of landing on an improvised runway. Also known as a field. Maybe they should have asked if they should prepare a runway for their guests, unless…

Yes. The plane slowed down even more until it came to a stop, hovering in the air about a hundred and fifty yards from their position, then descended straight down. Like an Osprey, but with jet engines. Jack wondered how they avoided FOD. And how fuel-efficient the thing was.

The plane set down, and the engine noise faded. A moment later, a door in the side opened - like a C-47, Jack thought - and two

armed soldiers stepped out, followed by four more soldiers. Probably officers, Jack thought - they were in uniform but didn't carry longarms.

Behind them, two more guards climbed out of the plane but stayed back while the six approached their position.

"Showtime," Jack said. "Let's see if you can do your magic again, Daniel."

"I'm no diplomat, Jack. I'm only here because I made first contact with them."

His friend was too modest. Jack would trust him over any career diplomat from Earth. Or any princess from Etheria, actually. He clapped Daniel on the back. "Just do your thing. No pressure."

"Tell that to Adora," Daniel whispered back.

Jack glanced at her. Yeah, Daniel was right - Adora looked tense. But that couldn't be helped now.

He put on his best smile as the Eurondans reached them.

"Yo!"

*****

Adora was used to Catra's antics, so her smile didn't slip as Jack greeted the Eurondan Alliance delegation far too casually. They didn't know Earth or Etheria, so they hopefully wouldn't realise it, anyway. "Hello," she said with a nod. "I'm She-Ra, princess of Power and Supreme Commander of the Alliance against the Goa'uld."

"I am Captain Akon," their apparent leader, a middle-aged man, said with a rather brief nod. He also focused on her while the others with him stared at Catra and Isa.

Unlike Alar's people, who all looked similar to each other, the delegation showed more diversity, Adora noted. In skin tone and height, at least - all of them were men, and all had dark hair, though while Akom's hair was curly, one of the guards hanging back had straight, long hair.

Catra rolled her eyes at the scrutiny. "No, you don't get to pull my tail to check if it's real," she said.

Adora cleared her throat as two of the younger Alliance soldiers blushed. "Anyway, this is Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, Princess Entrapta of Dryl, Princess Frosta of the Kingdom of Snows, General O'Neill, Major Carter, Dr Jackson, his wife Sha're, Tech-Master Bow, Catra and Emily," Adora introduced her friends.

"Lieutenants Kels and Pers. Liou." Akon curtly nodded at the three others with him. He didn't bother introducing the guards. Both Kels and Pers were younger men. The former had darker skin than Bow, and the latter looked like he would fit in the Eurondan Nation if he dyed his black hair. Liou was another middle-aged man with a skin tone similar to Frosta's, but he was rail-thin and taller than anyone else here except She-Ra. He was also focused on Catra and Emily, so he might be a scientist.

"We've prepared a tent for the meeting," Adora said, pointing at it. "And we brought some refreshments and snacks." She was sure that if they had been forced to eat yeast-based food like their enemies, they would appreciate it.

"It should be safe for human consumption - at least Alar's people wouldn't have any problems," Entrapta added. "We can scan you to check if you want to be sure."

"I think…" Akon started to reply, but Liou interrupted him. "How is your hair moving?"

Akon glared at him - scowled, actually - but didn't tell him off, Adora noted. So, Liou might be in charge of the delegation.

“It’s my magic power,” Entrapta told him with a smile - and demonstrated how she could control her hair to hold tools and operate computers. “All princesses have a magic power.”

“Yes!” Frosta nodded and took a step forward. “I control ice.” Before Adora could say anything to stop her, Frosta moved her hands, and a pillar of ice rose from the ground near them.

“And I can teleport,” Glimmer added while the delegation stared at the ice. Then she disappeared and appeared on top of the ice pillar.

“Show-offs,” Catra commented. Adora didn’t have to look at her lover to know she was rolling her eyes.

“It’s the quickest way to prove we’re not from this planet,” Glimmer retorted as she reappeared next to Adora. She turned to face Liou. “Do you want to examine our powers more closely?”

“I think so, yes.” Liou smiled at her. “Although while unprecedented, such powers wouldn’t prove that you’re from another world.”

“Magic powers. Advanced technology.” Glimmer gestured at Emily. “Catwoman.” She nodded at Catra. “And the plant life of most of a continent restored.”

“A compelling collection of arguments in favour of your claim, indeed.” Liou nodded once more. “Still, to have come through a ‘gate’ from another world…”

“Where else would we have come from? Do you think we are from the Eurondan Nation?” Catra scoffed.

“No, I don’t think so,” Liou replied. “As you might have found out, they consider anyone not conforming to their ideals, both biologically and philosophically, unworthy of living - they started a war over this stance. And most of you would not pass muster.”

“We’re aware of that,” Jack said. “We had a disagreement over that, which led to the big honking hole in their bunker.”

“But I think we should discuss that in the tent,” Adora added. “After you finish your examination, of course.”

“This shouldn’t take long,” Liou said. “I only brought a rudimentary set of tools.” He went and took a probe from the ice pillar, then peered at it through some sort of scanner.

“Oh! Spectral analysis!” Entrapta smiled.

Liou let a piece of ice melt in his hand and tasted it, ignoring Akon’s grimace. “It seems to be ordinary water,” he said. “Of course, given your demonstrated powers, that could be wrong.” He looked at Catra, who rolled her eyes again, though, despite her earlier words, she stretched and moved both her ears and tail.

“Intriguing. This is not your ‘magic power’, is it?” Liou asked. “You were not named as a princess.”

“No.” Catra smirked.

“And we’re all grateful for that,” Adora heard Glimmer mumble next to her.

She cleared her throat again. “So, shall we sit down? We have a lot to discuss.”

“We shall.” Liou’s smile didn’t change. “Such as the question of why you seem intent on protecting the same people who wanted to murder us all and would see you dead if they could.”

Adora suppressed a wince and kept smiling politely at him. “Yes, that.”

*****

They were off to a good start, in Samantha Carter’s opinion. Liou had - as far as she could tell - accepted that they were aliens. Or,

at the very least, not from the Eurondan Nation. That he was testing the facts more than any preconception was very promising, as was the fact that the obvious scientist of the delegation was apparently in charge.

Of course, that didn't change that the negotiations would be very difficult. Sam didn't have to be a trained diplomat to realise that ending the war while the Eurondan Nation and its people still existed wouldn't be popular in the Eurondan Alliance. Liou's comment, pointed if politely said, made it clear that they saw any interference that hindered their continuation of the war as help for their enemies.

Or so it seemed. As they took their seats, Sam reminded herself that they didn't know anything about the Eurondan Alliance that they hadn't been told by Alar and his people, who had every incentive to paint the worst picture of their enemies. And even that information had been very scant with regard to their society and culture. Mostly vague propaganda about the Alliance 'breeding uncontrollably'. Even if that were true - Sam doubted it - decades had passed since the war had started. Their society would have changed massively since then.

"Thank you for meeting with us," Adora told them.

"And have some tiny food!" Entrapta added, hair tendrils offering plates with finger food courtesy of Stargate Command's mess hall and a selection of all the drinks of the bases' vending machines to the delegation.

The three others glanced to Liou, Sam noted. Taking their cues from the scientist. Smart.

Liou himself looked at the food, then started sampling it. He hadn't attempted to check for poison, as far as Sam could tell. Perhaps he didn't have the means to do so quickly and in the field - Earth technology was limited in that are as well, after all. Though that was speculation. They might have deliberately held back their best scanners.

“Oh.” Liou’s eyebrows rose after a fist bite from an egg salad sandwich. “This is food from your home?”

“Yes,” Daniel told him. “We brought it through the Stargate in preparation for this meeting. It was made by the cooks on our base.”

“Ah.” Liou nodded. “This is the food your soldiers eat?”

“Sometimes,” Daniel replied. “It was specially prepared, but in a military base. Civilian chefs would have made better food, but the logistics of transporting such food in time for this meeting were too challenging. I hope it’s still sufficient.”

Liou slightly tilted his head. “Are your civilian chefs more skilled than your base’s cooks?”

“It depends,” Daniel told him. “Their general skill level varies, of course. And some civilian chefs are, well, not very good. But the best chefs are civilians.”

“It’s kind of hard to hire the best cooks when we can’t pay them more than a fraction of what a five-star restaurant can offer,” the General added. “But we manage.”

“Ah.” Liou exchanged a glance with Akon. “You call yourself the ‘Alliance against the Goa’uld’. Are you fighting a war?”

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. “They are an alien species that can take over a human body as a host and rule an Empire based on enslaving humans.”

Adora and Daniel briefly explained more about the Goa’uld Empire.

Liou and the others listened, but Sam had the impression that they were not convinced. She couldn’t really hold that against them; without proof - and personal experience - Sam would be doubtful of such claims as well. But it would make negotiations more difficult.

That was for the others to handle, though.

"...and that's how we arrived here," Adora finished their very brief explanation of how they had reached Euronda.

"I see. So, the Eurondan Nation allied with your rivals and supplied them with poison to attack your base?" Liou asked. "This sounds familiar."

Akon snorted at that.

"In hindsight, yes. At the time, we didn't know what the Eurondan Nation had done to your world," Daniel said.

"And then, when you met with them under the flag of truce, they betrayed you and attempted to murder you all," Liou went on.

"Yes. After they realised that we, ah, didn't share their views about eugenics and procreation, things deteriorated and escalated," Daniel said.

"We can see that." Liou nodded at Bow, Glimmer and the others. "It's remarkable that they allowed you to visit their base in the first place. They must have been more desperate than we thought."

"Desperate enough to ignore their own ideology and attempt to reach an agreement and trade deal," Daniel said.

"Temporarily," Liou corrected him. "They attacked you anyway."

"Through treachery," Akon added with a deep scowl. "When you had brought civilians to the meeting."

He glanced at Sha're, Sam noted. And at Glimmer. And at Entrapta. All members of the delegation were doing that, actually. Even the guards were doing it. Did they think everyone who wasn't in uniform was a civilian? They had been told that Adora was the military leader of the Alliance, though. And would they

realise what was a uniform and what was the personal outfit of a princess from the few samples they had?

No, she realised - Sha’re was wearing the same fatigues as Daniel was, and they were looking at her. They were also looking at Sam herself, she realised. And she had been introduced with her rank.

Oh. She pressed her lips together for a moment, trying not to scowl when she recognised what they were doing.

They were staring at every woman.

*****

Tense Negotiations Part 3

Restored Zone, Main Continent, Euronda, December 16th, 1999 (Earth Time)

Catra leaned back and stretched her arms over her head. The Eurondan Alliance delegation stared, as expected. But they were staring at everyone - well, almost everyone. That they would be staring at Adora was expected. Who wouldn't, whether she was She-Ra or not? But they were also staring - openly or with an attempt to be not obvious - at the others.

And something was odd.

Catra frowned a little, trying to spot the pattern.

"Do you have many civilians?" Sam suddenly asked. She was leaning forward and looked… annoyed, Catra noted. Which was a surprise.

Liou tilted his head at her. "Why do you ask?"

"You seem to be surprised by the presence of women at this meeting," Sam replied.

Oh! Catra rolled her eyes. That again!

"It's unusual for us," Liou told her. "Our circumstances must be very different, I suppose."

"Don't you have female soldiers?" Sam raised her eyebrows. Definitely annoyed.

Daniel blinked, then slowly nodded. He must have just got it as well.

And Adora was frowning.

“The idea to send women into war, risk their lives, is anathema to us,” Liou said. His group looked pretty uncomfortable to Catra.

Sexist, then. Probably thought women couldn’t fight, like some idiots on Earth. I wonder if they also have some stupid religion favouring men, Catra thought.

“Why?” Adora asked. “We can fight as well as any man.”

“Better,” Glimmer muttered under her breath. Louder, she added: “We’ve proven that in the war against the Horde.”

“Yes!” Frosta added with a sharp nod and a scowl.

At least they haven’t called her a kid, Catra thought. That would have set the princess off.

“As I said, our circumstances must be very different,” Liou said with a polite smile that was about as sincere as Horde Prime.

“You don’t have many women, do you?” Daniel asked.

Liou merely turned his head to face him, but the other three at the table visibly tensed. “What makes you say that?”

“Ah, it seems the most logical explanation,” Daniel explained in his lecturing voice. At least he didn’t raise a finger for each point. “You were fighting a war for your very survival, against a genocidal enemy. Usually, nations mobilise all resources for that. And since the war has been mostly fought in the air, with advanced aeroplanes, one would have expected you to recruit your women as well, so the most talented pilots could be used regardless of their gender. Even if you had strong traditions against such a move, the threat of genocide would likely have outweighed those - as happened to the Eurondan Nation when they made a deal with others not conforming to their ideals. And yet, you apparently didn’t even think about this. So, there might not be enough women in your country to risk any in combat.”

Liou's smile turned rueful, and he slowly nodded. "Your analysis is correct."

"Ah?" Daniel perked up but quickly schooled his features. "Sorry. I got a bit carried away."

"So, what - you don't have enough women to keep your population up?" Jack asked.

Oh. That was… Catra winced.

"You don't have artificial wombs?" Entrapta cocked her head at them before smiling widely. "We can help you out there!"

"'Artificial wombs'?" Liou looked intrigued.

The other Eurondans looked queasy, Catra noted.

"Well, there's also magic alternatives, but artificial wombs are the easiest way to have kids without a woman," Entrapta said.

"My dads used them," Bow added with a smile. "I've got twelve older siblings."

"Your dads had thirteen kids?" Akon shook his head. "That's… No wonder you risk women in combat if you can replenish your numbers so easily!"

"Ah… I'm the only soldier amongst them," Bow said, frowning a little. "They didn't have kids to 'replenish' our army."

"You shouldn't have children just to turn them into soldiers!" Adora blurted out.

"We were almost wiped out!" Akon protested. "The Eugenists struck at our civilians first, killing most of them!"

"They deliberately hit civilians over military targets?" Jack asked. He was almost as tense as the Eurondans had been.

"Yes," Akon said.

“Few civilians were able to reach a shelter when the poison was released,” Liou said. “The military did what they could, but they could barely protect themselves - and had to defend against the Eugenists’ attack at the same time. Civilian casualties were… crippling.”

“What did you do? To deal with that?” Daniel asked a little hesitantly.

“We fought them however we could!” Akon said. “And slowly, with great sacrifices, we drove them back! And now that we are on the brink of final victory, you interfere!”

Daniel winced but didn’t relent. “I meant, how did you handle your, ah, population crisis?”

“We ensured that most of the children conceived after the war had started were female,” Liou said. He glanced at the two younger Lieutenants. “Young men are also rare in our country, though not as critical for our survival as women since they aren’t required to be present - or alive - at conception.”

Oh.

Catra wasn’t the only one who winced at that.

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The Eurondan Nation had started by going after the civilian population? Jack O’Neill winced. In hindsight, that should have been obvious. It was a logical move - for genocidal scumbags waging a war of extermination - and they already knew that the Space Nazis had poisoned the entire planet to get at their enemies. Still…. Sick.

Maybe we should let the Eurondan Alliance finish them off, he thought.

“I see,” Daniel said. He looked shocked as well. “That’s quite an extreme measure, although the circumstances were extreme as

well."

The scientist, Liou, frowned. "It was a logical response to the loss of most of our civilian population."

"Most of your military was male, then?" Glimmer asked.

"Yes," Liou replied.

"That had always been the case," Akon added. "Why would we risk women in battle?"

"Because we can fight!" Frosta said.

Liou frowned at the man, Jack noted, if only long enough for the officer to notice and wince. "There were movements to recruit more women, before the war," he said. "Partially in response to the Eurondan Nation recruiting women. But after the war had started and we had lost so many people…" He shook his head. "Our leaders agreed that we could not afford to risk women in combat. Not if we wanted to survive as a people. Even so, many succumbed to hunger and sickness as lost medical infrastructure and food production took their toll, and we struggled to defend ourselves and build the means to sustain our lives in shelters."

Yeah, that would have been horrible. Losing most of their population and their food production? Jack didn't even want to imagine how bad things must have been if they had been caught unaware by such an attack without sufficient food in storage for the population. Every lost soldier probably was also a boon since that meant the food supply would last longer…

"So, the current absence of women in the ranks of our soldiers is a result of our situation in the past," Liou went on.

Jack suppressed a snort. Liou was smart, but his attempt to pander to the Alliance led by a woman was a bit too obvious. By now, Akon's attitude was probably entrenched amongst the entire Eurondan Alliance.

Catra didn’t suppress her snort.

“Well, that’s no longer necessary. We can supply you with artificial wombs, and you can recruit women into your army again!” Entrapta told them with a smile.

Jack winced again - she had completely misread the room.

“Anyway, you won’t have to recruit more soldiers once the war’s over - and it effectively is over,” Adora said. “The Eurondan Nation can no longer wage war against you.”

“So you say. And their last bunker did suffer obvious damage. Yet, even our most optimistic estimate of the extent of their defensive network puts their bunker as far too large that such damage would have annihilated their production capacity,” Liou retorted. “Left alone, they will recover.”

“And they’ll renew their attacks on us!” Akon said. “We cannot let them threaten our people ever again - we have to wipe them out for good!”

“We do not condone genocide,” Glimmer said with narrowed eyes.

“You obviously have never suffered as we have!” Akon spat. “Or you would not say this!”

“We have fought for our very lives as well!” Glimmer retorted. “But we didn’t ‘wipe out’ our enemies when we won!”

“You don’t have to destroy your enemy to be safe,” Adora added. “They can’t hurt you any more - we won’t let them.”

“As long as they are around, we’ll be in danger. They see us as subhumans and claim our very existence threatens them,” Liou pointed out. “You cannot trust them to keep the peace.”

“They tried to exterminate us and almost succeeded. Our soldiers threw them back at great cost!” Akon almost yelled. “How can you

expect us to let them live after all they did to us? They do not deserve any mercy!”

They weren’t entirely wrong, Jack had to admit.

“All of them? Even their civilians?” Adora shook her head. “Their children? Those kept in stasis?”

“Stasis?” Liou leaned forward. “What do you mean?”

“They keep most of their civilians in stasis, cryogenic sleep,” Entrapta explained. “They don’t have the supplies for them.”

“Ah, I see.” Liou nodded. “That answers a few questions we had, thank you.”

“You’re welcome!”

Jack suppressed a sigh. At least it was intel about the Eurondan Nation and not about the Alliance.

“Anyway,” Adora spoke up again, “We won’t let you kill the Eurondan Nation. They cannot hurt you any more. And we’ll ensure that they cannot hurt you in the future either.”

“And how will you be doing this? Will you remove them from our world?” Liou asked, tilting his head again. “Will you take them to your own worlds?”

“That would be ethnic cleansing,” Daniel pointed out with a frown. “It is frowned upon on Earth.”

“So, you expect us to share our world with the very people who tried their hardest to ruin it only so they could murder us all?” Liou shook his head. “That is unacceptable. We have lived too long in fear of them. We have suffered too much to forgive them.”

“One way or the other, they have to be removed from our world,” Akon added.

Once again, Jack couldn't help thinking that they had a point.

*****

Adora clenched her teeth. She understood the Eurondan Alliance's views. They had lost so much! Suffered for so long!

But they were still wrong. And she said so. "You're wrong." Akon and the two lieutenants openly glared at her. Liou was a bit less obvious, but he still frowned. Adora shook her head at all. "You can be safe without *removing* them." They were already safe - they just didn't accept it.

"No, we can't!" Akon disagreed. Vehemently. "You can't live under the same sky as those who murdered your family!"

"If you murder their families, does that make you any better than they were?" Adora asked.

"Yes! We didn't start the war! We didn't try to murder civilians!" Akon retorted.

"But that's what you are trying now," Daniel pointed out.

"What?" Akon spat.

Daniel pushed his glasses up. "You are trying to kill all of the Eurondan Nation's population. Most of them are held in stasis, helpless - civilians."

"They tried to kill us all! Our families! Our world!" Akon shook his head.

"And all of them went along with it!" Kel added. "They are all guilty!"

Pers nodded in obvious agreement, his lips pressed together.

"And we are not arguing for their deaths - merely for their removal from our world - the world they attempted to ruin to kill

us all," Liou added in a - in Adora's opinion - deceptively mild voice.

"That is only an option because you now know about the Stargate," Glimmer retorted.

"And removing people from their homes is still ethnic cleansing," Daniel said. "Some consider it a form of genocide. But it is generally agreed that it is not lawful."

"A general agreement amongst *your* people, maybe," Liou retorted. "My people differ."

"We will never accept that those monsters remain on our world!" Akon said.

"We're here to discuss a truce," Sha're cut in. "We can discuss terms for a peace agreement with your leaders at a later date."

Right. Adora pressed her lips together and hoped she wasn't blushing. They were not talking to the leaders of the Eurondan Alliance. Just to their delegation sent to check if Adora and her friends were liars. Perhaps their leaders would be more reasonable. "Yes," she said. "You've seen that we told you the truth. Do you accept a truce?"

"A truce at this point would seriously hinder our efforts to end the war," Liou said.

"You've already suspended your attacks," Daniel pointed out.

Liou nodded. "Yes, we did. This was a decision that was not taken lightly and has, undoubtedly, allowed our enemies time to recover. Agreeing to a longer truce would compound this."

"Continuing your attacks will endanger our own people currently providing humanitarian help here," Daniel said.

"And we won't let you do that!" Frosta spat with a glare.

“You’re helping our enemies!” Akon blurted out. “Do you expect us to ignore that?”

“We’re helping *everyone* here,” Adora corrected him. “We’ve restored a lot of your world already.” She pointed at their surroundings.

“So you claim!” Pers retorted. “We haven’t seen proof for that!”

“Do I need to create another statue?” Frosta asked, ice forming over her hands. “Maybe of you looking stupid?”

Catra snickered next to Adora.

Liou studied Frosta. “Perhaps not quite as big. But it would be illuminating.”

“What?” Pers gaped.

But Frosta was already moving her hands, and a statue formed and grew right next to her. It was a passable portrait of the Lieutenant, in Adora’s opinion. It also was forming inside the tent. Fortunately, Frosta stopped when it reached the ceiling.

“Intriguing.” Liou peered at the ice.

“It’s my magic power,” Frosta told him with a smirk.

“Magic?” Akon scoffed.

“Yes, magic,” Glimmer told him. “We’ve restored magic to your world as well. Those amongst you with the talent for it will be able to work magic.”

“But we’re here to focus on a truce,” Adora reminded them. “This is just proof that we are already helping your world - all of your world.”

“By introducing magic to the world?” Liou raised his eyebrows.

“By restoring what was destroyed during the war,” Adora told him, narrowing her eyes a little. “We’re here to help you - all of you.” Why couldn’t they see that?

“And yet you wish to protect our enemies. Enemies that conducted a genocide, which you claim not to condone. I think this is a slight contradiction,” Liou retorted.

“We do not condone genocide,” Glimmer told him. “No matter the victims.”

“You would protect the murderers from the consequences of their own actions?” Akon scoffed.

“We’d also protect you from becoming murderers.” Glimmer bared her teeth at him.

“Defending ourselves and avenging our deaths is not murder!” Akon mirrored her.

“That is a false equivalency. If your enemy is helpless and you keep attacking, you’re no longer defending yourself,” Daniel objected. “And vengeance is not justice.”

“We will not allow them to endanger our people again!”

“They won’t,” Adora told him. “You don’t have to murder them for that.”

“After all they have done, we cannot trust them!” Akon shook his head almost violently.

“You ask a lot of us,” Liou added.

“We just ask you to let us help,” Adora told him.

“Yes.” Liou nodded. “That requires trust - and it is hard to trust someone who seems more concerned with protecting our genocidal enemies than our own people.”

Adora clenched her teeth. They did not understand! Why didn't they understand?

"Well, it's not just about trust," Catra said. "It's also about risks." She leaned forward. "Do you really want to risk waging a war against us? All that you've seen here?" She cocked her head at the statue. "The plants outside? She gestured at the tent entrance. "That's just a very small part. You haven't seen our spaceships. Or our armies."

"Do they fit through the Stargate?" Liou asked. His smile wasn't very smug, but a little was there.

"Some actually do," Jack said. "But that's beside the point."

"We're here to help you - we've restored a lot of your world already," Adora repeated herself. "We can offer even more help."

"Artificial wombs! And specially designed plants to finish the planet's restoration. For starters," Entrapta added.

"Yes." Adora nodded.

"Trust me, you don't want the Alliance as an enemy," Catra said with a smirk. "You really don't."

Liou glanced at the others. "I think this meeting has run its course. We have to inform our leaders about everything we've heard."

"Please do." Adora smiled. "And tell them that we would like to meet them."

They had to talk to their leaders to sort this out.

Liou nodded again.

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Eurondan Nation, Euronda, December 17th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Yes, I see it. Yes, I can change the plants to adapt to that - and filter out the poison. Maybe I should have them deposit the poison in some outgrowths for easier disposal? Then the rest of the plant could be used as feed or base for fertiliser…"

Samantha Carter nodded at the suggestion even though she didn't think Perfuma was talking to her right now. Watching the princess work with plants was still slightly unnerving - even more so after working with Loki in Alpha. Perfuma could alter a plant's genetic makeup with a thought. *Drastically* alter it - creating new plant species was child's play for her. What even a team of scientists with Ancient technology took weeks to months to achieve, she could do in seconds. Without any tools, just her magic power. And within her area of effect, fortunately limited, she could use her magic power to make the new plants grow as fast as Frosta could create ice.

Sam didn't want to imagine what Perfuma could do with the power of She-Ra at her disposal. She couldn't help doing it anyway, of course. And she was very grateful that Perfuma was such a nice person.

"Alright, I think that's it!" Perfuma turned and beamed at Sam. Next to her, green plants shot from the ground, wrapping around each other to form a trunk on top of which a slightly red fruit - or berry - formed, quickly growing. "The plants will spread out and focus all the poison into the fruits here. Once you remove the fruit, the plants will wither and turn to fertiliser! Same as when they run out of poison to filter."

"And the fruit?" Sam asked.

"Oh, that won't wither or decay. It will keep so you can collect them - which you should. They're very poisonous, after all." Perfuma frowned. "I tried to find a way for the plant to filter the poison out and turn it into something useful or at least inert, but I

didn’t manage.” She bit her lower lip. “The poison is too powerful for that, sorry.”

Sam was almost happy to hear that Perfuma had more limits. She didn’t let that show, of course. “The Eurondan Nation is very skilled at creating poison,” she said instead. “It’s a great thing that you managed to create a plant that can handle it in the first place.”

“Oh, that was nothing. Just some adaption of the plants I created for the Fright Zone. Once you have it worked out, you just have to adapt the biological filters for other substances.” She nodded, then blinked. “Speaking of that… Have you heard anything about my proposal to create filtering plants for your oceans? They could deal with the plastic and pollution!”

“The United Nations are still discussing it,” Sam said. And would likely keep doing that for some time.

“Ah.” Perfuma nodded with a sigh. “I hope they’ll accept my offer soon.”

Sam managed not to wince. Even several of the members of the Alliance were loath to allow genetically engineered organisms into the wild, much less on such a scale. And other nations hated anything that was related to magic. Or just hated the Alliance and objected to any proposal supported by them on principle.

She changed the subject. “Did you look over the seed samples from the vaults?”

“Yes!” Perfuma perked up. “I can make them grow easily! Although it will take some time to figure out where each species would do best. I don’t think we’ll be able to recreate how things were before their war even if we had perfect records. With the loss of plants, the climate changed, and reintroducing plant life will cause new changes… adapting the restored plants will take some time.”

"And that's not going to cover animals," Sam added. The Eurondans had kept genetic samples but hadn't been very thorough to begin with, and they lacked the technology to grow animals from those samples. And they had focused on livestock, not on all the species crucial for a balanced ecosystem. "We'll have to import several species from Earth."

"Yes. The filter plants can pollinate using wind, but other plants need insects. I could change them, but I think the Eurondans want their original plants back." Perfuma looked around. "Well, I think we're done here. The plants will spread from here to the rest of the contaminated zone on this continent but probably not to the other landmasses. We'll have to drop seeds there."

Sam nodded. She was done with her scans as well. And the sensors she had planted were working as planned - if the Eurondan Alliance sent aeroplanes this way, they'd get advance warning.

They walked back to the skiff, where Emily was waiting for them. The skiff would be overloaded with the two of them and the bot, but it was manageable. And Emily's shield generator made it worth it. Entrapta was planning to adapt similar generators to their skiffs for tomorrow's truce meeting but hadn't managed to finish in time for this trip. Sadly, the shield generators they had installed around the defence complex were too large for the skiffs.

Something they had missed when constructing the things - they fit NATO standards for transportation, but the Etherian skiffs didn't conform to those specs. Logistics wouldn't be pleased.

But that was their problem, not Sam's.

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Restored Zone, Main Continent, Euronda, December 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So… any bets on whether or not this is a trap?"

Catra rolled her eyes at Jack's question. If he really thought that this was a trap, he would have argued against everyone else coming along. Even though they should be able to spot a trap thanks to their scanners - and, between Emily's shield and Glimmer, could safely evacuate everyone. This was just small talk, Jack-style.

"I don't think it's a trap," Adora replied honestly. "They seemed to believe us - and they have seen more of what we're doing yesterday."

"Oh, they do believe us, or they wouldn't have stopped their bombing runs and stuck to recon flights," Jack said. "But they want to continue the war."

No surprise there, Catra thought. The Eurondan Nation had killed most of the Eurondan Alliance's civilians. And deliberately, not as collateral damage or something. Not that that made much of a difference for the dead. She clenched her teeth, remembering Thaynor. She had flattened the village as her first mission as Force Captain. She couldn't even tell herself that it had been a mission to root out Alliance soldiers hiding there or to draw out nearby Alliance forces to defend the village in order to engage them. Those were just excuses. They had struck the place with overwhelming forces right away. Well, overwhelming forces until She-Ra had appeared…

She shook her head, trying to force the memories of that confrontation away. She hadn't gone for murdering all civilians. Just let her troops run wild and looked away when needed. But 'not as bad as the people who ruined an entire planet and murdered most of its population' wasn't anything to be proud of - it was up there with 'not as bad as Horde Prime'.

Fuck it. Fuck herself.

She stepped out of the tent with a mumbled 'checking the perimeter'. The air outside was clean, according to the sensors,

but she still smelt a hint of… something that reminded her of the Fright Zone. Or that was just her memories.

She stared at the horizon. Hilly country, there. No mountains - it wouldn't really stop armoured warfare, but it would slow down advances and channel thrusts, allowing defenders to use artillery from cover on choke points and kill zones. Would have to use air or aerospace forces to suppress the artillery and send in light troops to recon and screen the heavy armour. And to clear out any settlements of enemy infantry, of course…

She gasped when she felt an arm wrap around her shoulders. How had Adora snuck up on her without Catra noticing? Because she had been lost in her guilt.

"You're not like them."

Not any more, maybe, Catra added silently. Would she have gone for genocidal attacks like the Eurondans had? Deliberately trying to exterminate the entire population of the Princess Alliance? She hadn't done it. Not even when she had been at her lowest point. But if she had thought it was the only way to win, would she have done it? The Horde propaganda had claimed they were fighting against evil princesses to free the people, but everyone - except for Adora - had known that was a lie. A lie that had gotten some lip service in the field, at most. What if the Horde propaganda had been different? Made the enemy out to be all fanatical, treacherous foes who would never stop fighting and so must all be killed?

"I could have been like them," she whispered. She had risked the entire world to win, after all.

"But you weren't," Adora retorted.

She was so confident. Trusting. Loving.

Catra sighed and leaned into her lover a bit more. "I feel bad about telling the Eurondan Alliance to stop fighting their enemies." Selfish. Like a hypocrite.

“We’re saving them from becoming as bad as their enemies,” Adora said.

“They don’t see it like that.”

“They’re wrong. No matter what was done to them, murdering people in return is wrong. Vengeance won’t make anything right.” Adora nodded firmly.

Catra sighed again. Vengeance might be wrong, but she knew how tempting it was to strike back at whoever hurt you - at whoever you thought had hurt you. To make them hurt in turn. To make them suffer. To make them pay.

She understood them.

“They won’t thank us for this,” she said in a low voice. The Eurondan Alliance might end up hating them. Easily. Catra understood that as well.

“I know. But we can’t let them murder helpless people. That would be wrong.”

And that was what it boiled down to, in the end.

Catra nodded. “We won’t.”

No matter what it took.

*****

Another day, another meeting. That summed up Jack O’Neill’s life as a general. Granted, it was a meeting under truce to negotiate an armistice, on an alien planet, and he was with his friends and not in Brussels meeting with fellow generals, politicians or contractors, and if things went wrong, they’d have to evacuate under fire and try to find a way to save this world and their lives. So, it felt more like a Stargate Command mission with SG-1.

But he still felt ill at ease. He wasn't a diplomat. He was a soldier. And he wanted to remain a soldier. He was good at soldiering. He wasn't that good at diplomacy.

And he really sucked at trying to protect Space Nazis from suffering the consequences of their actions.

He still smiled when the transport plane of the Eurondan Alliance touched down, and a larger group than last time got out. Those weren't the Space Nazis, after all - those were the people who had fought years, decades, against the Space Nazis. And this time, they were meeting their leaders.

Jack wasn't surprised to spot Liou amongst the delegation. Just from the way everyone else had deferred to him, It had been rather obvious that the man hadn't been a low-ranking, expendable scientist. But Jack focused on the new faces. All of them were in uniform, which was expected. All of them were men. That was kind of a surprise - he would have expected them to bring at least one woman with them now that they knew that the Alliance was represented by Adora and the other princesses. On the other hand, they might have realised that just bringing a token woman along would only highlight that the Eurondan Alliance was run by men - and by soldiers.

The apparent leader was in the centre, a step ahead of the rest. Old but still spry - he walked briskly and sure-footed - he was tall, thin and bald, with a wispy moustache, and reminded Jack of a Japanese veteran from the Pacific War whom he had met on leave in Japan when he had been a fresh-faced Lieutenant. Liou was on his right side. To his left walked another old man. This one was stockier, with a bushy mane of white hair, and looked more like someone from the Middle East. Two more middle-aged soldiers walked behind them, and Jack tagged them as officers. They had that vibe. Unlike the two middle-aged guards bringing up the rear.

"Hello!" Adora greeted them with a wide smile. "I'm She-Ra, Princess of Power, and I represent the Alliance against the Goa'uld." She gestured at the others and introduced them.

The Eurondans nodded, and Liou introduced the new people in turn. "Commander Lan, a senior member of our Council. General Faisa, member of our general staff. Majors Kele and Janis, their aides."

Or spooks posing as aides, Jack thought. Analysts, probably - they would be useful for the negotiations and for gathering general intel.

"Please step inside the tent. We've prepared more diverse food than last time," Adora told them.

Liou perked up at that, and his polite smile grew more genuine. Or that was what he wanted you to think - whether he was a politician or a spook in addition to a scientist, Jack didn't know, but he would have to be skilled at hiding his emotions either way. As a scientist as well, of course - the stories Daniel had of the academic scene sometimes made the Pentagon look like it was staffed by straight shooters, and Liou was a soldier *and* a scientist.

Adora was right about the food. They hadn't pulled out all the stops, but they had ordered this food from actual caterers. High-class caterers.

Jack smiled widely as he snatched some choice snacks for himself.

Lan nodded in apparent appreciation and smiled at Adora after his first snack, but that didn't mean anything in Jack's opinion. Faisa grunted, still looking stern. Liou appeared to enjoy himself - and commented about the new selection - and Kele and Janis seemed to spend as much time looking at the food as they spent actually tasting it.

Jack was leaning more strongly towards both of them being intel analysts. On Earth, those could be, and not too rarely were, former field agents. Euronda might not have had much use for recon and spying on the enemy with their atmosphere being poisoned to the point of rendering field ops impossible, but any

country at war would have had spooks watching their own people - especially their soldiers.

Jack kept an eye on both. And the guards, of course. They had been betrayed and ambushed by one group of Eurondans before, and he'd be damned if he'd let it happen again.

*****

As expected after their first meeting, the Eurondan delegation liked the food. They even made some small talk about the different dishes. And Adora didn't have to tell Catra not to hog all fish sandwiches. The Eurondan leaders were smiling - except for General Faisa, but he hadn't smiled at all so far, so he probably didn't count. All in all, they were off to a good start.

However, the real challenge was to get the Eurondan Alliance to agree to an armistice and then negotiate a peace treaty. Adora had no illusions that that would be easy. But they were talking, at least.

She cleared her throat when everyone seemed to have had their fill - with the exception of Catra, who just grabbed another salmon toast, and Jack, who probably thought he was sneaky by snatching bowls of dessert. "So… shall we start the talks?"

Everyone grew serious at once. Liou was the only one to keep smiling but switched to doing so politely rather than genuinely.

"Yes," Commander Lan said. "And first, I want to protest your interference with a matter limited to Euronda."

"Our intervention was a reaction to the Eurondans supplying weapons that were used to attack us," Adora retorted. "We could not ignore that."

"According to your own claims, you stopped that. So, there's no longer any reason to meddle in this conflict." Lan leaned forward. "You achieved your goals."

“Our goal is to protect civilians,” Adora told him. Did he just try to use their own argument against them? “*Any* civilians.”

“The Eurondan Nation has no civilians. All of them are soldiers.”

“The majority of their population are in stasis, not fighting,” Daniel cut in.

Adora nodded. They had gone over that already.

“That doesn’t make them civilians - they are held in reserve,” Faisa spoke up. “They’re soldiers.”

“Even the children?” Glimmer scoffed. “If you declare every potential recruit a soldier, that would make any civilian a valid target.”

“They tried to murder all of our civilians,” Lan said with narrowed eyes. “And they almost succeeded. We are merely retaliating in kind.”

“That doesn’t justify attacking helpless civilians,” Adora objected. “Two wrongs don’t make a right.”

“Do you really want to stoop as low as your enemies?” Glimmer added. “That would make you no better than them.”

“We didn’t start this!” Lan protested with an open scowl. “We are just defending ourselves. As long as the Eurondan Nation exists, we’re not safe. They will try to exterminate us again!”

“That’s not true!” Adora shook her head, “People can change!”

“We have had similar conflicts in our past - on Earth - and the nation that waged a war of extermination did change profoundly. It happened within living memory.” Daniel nodded at the Eurondans. “They were actually quite similar to your enemies in that they, too, had an ideology of racial purity. And they murdered millions of civilians.”

“Damn Nazis,” Jack muttered near Adora.

“But they changed,” Adora said. The Germans were good friends now - and good allies. “Everyone can change.”

“Not the Eugenists.” Faisa shook his head. “They have done too much.”

“And just because there’s a potential for change doesn’t mean that change will actually occur,” Liou said. “When pressed and desperate, people can claim and promise anything, only to go back on their word once their situation improves.”

“The Eugenists cannot be trusted.” Lan nodded slowly. “Nor can they be forgiven.”

Adora pressed her lips together. That attitude was wrong!

“Because they did something unforgivable, you will do something unforgivable to them?” Daniel pushed his glasses up.

“It’s not the same. We need to do this so our people - those amongst them who survived - can be safe again,” Lan insisted.

“Though we do not need to kill the remaining members of the Eurondan Nation,” Liou added. “As I mentioned before, exile from our world might be enough, provided that they are deprived of any opportunity ever to return.”

“As we mentioned before, that would be ethnic cleansing - something we do not condone on Earth,” Daniel said.

“Euronda is not Earth,” Faisa spat.

“On Earth, we consider human rights universal - applicable to any human and arguably any other sapient being, anywhere,” Daniel retorted.

“That’s your opinion, not ours,” Lan said. “Are you going to attempt to force your laws on us?”

“We won’t let you commit genocide,” Glimmer told him.

Adora nodded.

“Would you protect murderers even if it meant fighting their victims?” Lan asked.

“We will do what we have to to protect civilians.” Adora stared at him. He had to understand that they wouldn’t let them murder the Eurondans. Or drive them from their homes. That would be wrong no matter what they had done.

“But we won’t let them hurt you either,” Daniel said. “You will be safe.”

“So you say.” Lan scoffed. “And we should trust you? Trust the safety, the lives of our people, to you?”

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly.

Daniel cleared his throat. “Not blindly. When our, ah, version of the Eurondan Nation was defeated, they were disarmed, and their country was occupied. A coalition of their enemies controlled their territory until they were deemed trustworthy again.”

“You offer to let us occupy their territory? Which we would take anyway without your interference? How generous!” Faisa snorted.

“Without our ‘interference’, meaning, without us wrecking their base, you would have to struggle to take their territory,” Jack cut in. “And without us, they might have found new resources to turn the tables on you before you managed to defeat them.”

“That’s speculation,” Liou pointed out.

“They had already made deals with some of our rivals for the resources they needed,” Jack retorted. “You’d have a costly war to fight in either case.”

“We only have your word for that,” Lan objected.

“You also have a crater in the Eurondan nation’s base - and a restored continent,” Glimmer said, rolling her eyes. “And we offered you artificial wombs to help you restore your population. What else do we have to do to make you trust us?” She leaned forward. “We don’t want to fight you. We just want to protect the civilians.”

“You’ve won the war,” Daniel added. “And you will be safe from them. You can focus on rebuilding your world instead of on the war.”

“For how long?” Lan shook his head. “We need more than your word to accept an end to the war without the complete destruction of our enemy. We need proof. Guarantees.”

“And you’ll get them,” Adora said. “You can watch as their weapons are destroyed.”

“And I guess we can send a squadron of frigates over,” Catra commented with a shrug. “To keep everyone honest.”

“Cheaper than an occupation force,” Jack said.

Adora nodded. They could do that. They would have to protect the planet from the Goa’uld anyway.

“And we want those who attacked us and murdered our people,” Lan said. “They aren’t civilians. They have to pay for what they did to us.”

“Our dead demand justice,” Faisa growled.

Adora winced. That would complicate things.

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Tense Negotiations Part 4

Gate Room, Euronda, December 18th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"You want us to betray our soldiers? Those who fought the hardest for us? Stab our own in the back after all they suffered for our sake?"

Samantha Carter was glad she wasn't standing too close to Alar - the man was literally spitting mad.

"The Eurondan Alliance wants to try the ones responsible for the genocide of their people," Adora told him. "They insisted on that."

They also insisted on complete disarmament of the Eurondan Nation, but Alar either had missed that or didn't care as much about his nation as he cared about his own fate - his name was almost at the top of the war criminal list that Commander Lan had handed over - obviously prepared in advance. Sam wasn't quite sure how much of his insistence had been simply posturing to improve his position in the negotiation, but the man was a shrewd negotiator, and they had already said that this was just their condition to start negotiations, not the sum of their demands.

Of course, Sam perfectly understood and supported his demand for justice. Letting Nazis go free just to facilitate a peace treaty… Well, the United States had done worse in the past, but that didn't make it right.

Alar shook his head. "And you agreed to that? You could easily stop them! Crush their forces as you crushed ours!"

"Well, you see - they didn't supply poison to our enemies and then tried to kill all of us." The General shrugged. "Call me petty, but I think that's a kinda important difference."

Sam did neither smile nor roll her eyes at his comment. But she did smile at Alar's gasp - the former and possibly present leader of the Eurondan Nation seemed shocked.

Unfortunately, he quickly rallied. “But you said you would protect us! We’re helpless in the face of your enemies - most of our people are held in stasis!”

Adora nodded. “And we will protect your people. We won’t let them kill you.”

Alar looked relieved, but before he could say anything, the General added: “That doesn’t mean we won’t let you get punished for your crimes. The death sentence might be off the table, but prison isn’t.”

Alar gasped again. “But… it was war! We only defended ourselves against a threat to the very heart of our nation!”

“By starting a war.” Mermista rolled her eyes. “That’s a very active defence.”

“We had no choice but to launch an attack. If we had waited any longer, we would not have had any chance at victory!”

“Well, you can tell that to the judge,” the General said.

“We won’t accept such a treaty!” Alar shook his head almost violently. “We’d rather fight to our last soldier!”

Glimmer snorted at that. “I doubt that. Your former subordinates were quick to abandon you in order to kill us. I’m sure the first ranking officer not on the list of war criminals will quickly hand you over rather than die for you.”

Alar seemed to have no answer to that.

“How did they know our leaders, anyway?” Tralan spoke up. He hadn’t commented until now. “I didn’t think they had captured any of us. How would they know our names?”

“They didn’t. They asked us,” the General told him.

“What?”

Adora cleared her throat. “They had the names of your leaders at the start of the war. And they also asked for their successors.”

“And we told them,” Glimmer added. “We’re not going to lie for you, and it would have come out anyway - as soon as your next subordinate wants to replace you.”

“But…” Alar blinked and then looked around in the gate room.

Sam didn’t look away when he met her eyes. By any reasonable standards, the man was a genocidal war criminal. And his people had tried to kill her friends and herself.

“We’ll ensure you will get a fair trial and that you won’t get executed if you’re found guilty.” Adora smiled encouragingly at him.

“But…”

Daniel was smiling as well. “You were ready to die for your people, right? To give your life to save them? Losing your freedom instead of your life to save them should be a better outcome.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded several times. “Because you’ll be alive. And prisons aren’t that bad - I spent some time in a cell as well. Just don’t break out; they don’t like that.”

Alar stared at her in apparent bafflement.

“And if you ask nicely, we’ll build you a pretty prison with all the best cells.” The General bared his teeth at Aral. “It’ll probably be more comfortable than spending your life in this bunker. At least as a common soldier.”

He had been sarcastic, but Entrapta nodded eagerly. “Oh, yes! We can do that! We have to rebuild much of your planet’s infrastructure anyway, so adding a nice prison won’t be much more work! Oh! Do you want to stay on the surface? We could build a prison in space!”

"If you're found guilty. You weren't in charge when the war started, were you?" Glimmer asked.

"No…" Alar slowly shook his head. "No, I wasn't. That was my father."

The man looked entirely too relieved for Sam's taste.

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Gate Room, Euronda, December 19th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"All of the Eurondans responsible for the attack that wrecked the planet's biosphere are dead already?"

Catra snorted - even Adora sounded incredulous.

Alar, though, nodded. Almost eagerly. At least, he managed not to appear smug. "Yes. My father ordered the attack as a preemptive strike. He died ten years into the war - the stress of leading our people through such an ordeal was too much for him. I asked him to step down and go into stasis years before that, but he wouldn't listen. He said that would be like abandoning his duty to our people."

Oh, yes! Catra could totally see Alar asking his dear old father to step down and let him take over. For his own good, of course. She scoffed. The man was a schemer, like many of his subordinates - who had quickly accepted his leadership once again after hearing that their enemies wanted to try their leaders for their crimes.

Alar glanced at her for a moment, then turned back to look at Adora.

"He wouldn't have acted alone. He had others to plan and launch the attack," Adora said.

"Subordinates following his orders," Alar retorted. "Although most of them are dead by now as well, so whether or not they would have been able to stop him is moot."

"'Most of them'?" Adora frowned.

"One is in stasis, though his mental health had deteriorated to the point of being unable to fulfil his duty - he was in charge of our aero-fighters and personally led many strikes. Too many." Alar sighed far too theatrically. "I fear he is not fit to stand trial."

"I think that's what the court will have to judge," Catra commented, earning another glance.

"Yes," Adora agreed. "Whether or not he can stand trial will be up to the Eurondan Court of Justice."

An important-sounding name. It was too bad they hadn't been able to agree on anything else regarding the court.

Alar frowned some more. "Taking him out of stasis will endanger his life."

"We can heal him," Adora said.

"And we can't let him remain in stasis forever anyway," Catra added.

"You can heal him?" Alar didn't sound as happy as Catra had expected. Even counting the fact that he was charged with attempted genocide as well.

"I think so," Adora said. "It won't hurt to try, in any case."

"Healing him only so the Breeders can execute him seems cruel and unusual," Alar pointed out - probably misquoting the law books they had given the Eurondans.

"He won't be executed," Adora said. "We won't budge on that. The death penalty is barbaric."

"I was under the impression that the death penalty was still in use on Earth." Alar looked confused.

Catra snorted. Had the Eurondan expected to understand Earth after an evening reading a few law books? She'd spent months on Earth, immersed in its news and media, and still didn't really understand most of the planet. Then again, Earth had billions of people - magnitudes more than any other planet they knew - and hundreds of countries and distinct regions.

"Some of our allies still have the death penalty, yes." Adora frowned deeply. "But not the military code of justice for the alliance."

"We're supposed to kill the Goa'uld, not each other," Catra added.

"We're supposed to defeat them," Adora corrected her.

Catra nodded, even though she was sure that the Jaffa - the rebels amongst them - wouldn't want to spare any of the snakes. And given that they still hadn't found a way to provide the Goa'uld with artificial hosts that didn't degrade their minds, she wasn't sure if killing them wouldn't be kinder than keeping them in tanks and lobotomised for the rest of their lives. And keeping them all in stasis would only kick the whole thing down the road.

Still better than letting them breed, though - if they didn't eat their young, they would quickly outnumber everyone else. You'd probably needed a von Neumann Swarm, as Entrapta called them, to keep up with making tanks for so many snakes. But that was a problem for the time after the war against the Goa'uld.

"Speaking of the court… We still protest being judged by foreigners and Breeders," Alar said.

Someone should tell him that using slurs like 'Breeders' won't make a good impression on others, Catra thought.

"We haven't finalised the curt's makeup yet," Adora said.

"But since you refused to allow us on the court, it's clear that it will be made up by the Breeders and you," Alar retorted. "At least,

I hope you will not break your word and hand us over to our enemies."

"We won't," Adora said. "But letting you judge yourself is out of the question. We'll be using Alliance laws for this."

"Laws neither we nor the Breeders had ever adopted," Alar protested.

"That's why it's fair," Catra said, flashing her fangs at him.

"If both you and the Eurondan Alliance agree that something shouldn't be punished, we will defer to that," Adora told him.

Alar scoffed. "Even if there is such a case, I doubt they will be honest enough to admit it!"

"We'll see," Adora said. "Earth has a lot of experience with such trials."

That was… not lying, but not entirely accurate either. But Earth certainly had more experience with such trials - or any trials - than the Princess Alliance, much less the Horde. Etheria would still have to send a judge or more, depending on the final numbers, of course. Couldn't completely leave this up to Earth.

But as long as it didn't directly involve Catra or her love, she was fine with that. They had spent too long on this planet already, in her opinion.

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Restored Zone, Main Continent, Euronda, December 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

As Jack O'Neill glanced around the landscape, waiting for the Eurondan Alliance delegation to arrive, movement in the air caught his attention - was that a bird? There weren't supposed to be any birds on the planet. Entrapta and Carter were still working on picking which *bugs* to introduce to the Euronda, and the team

on Alpha had barely begun to study the gene samples from the Space Nazis' vaults to clone animals from.

He narrowed his eyes, trying to track the thing. It wasn't flying like a bird… Oh. Jack snorted - it was a spy bot. He should have realised that at once - they had been spreading them out over the planet. Soon, they'd cover the system as well. And the squadron of frigates making their way over here was dropping spy bots along their route as well. Once the system was linked to the network, they wouldn't need to open a gate to communicate.

But that was for the future. They still had to end the war here. Formally. The Eurondans had stopped fighting, the Space Nazis because they had lost the capability to hold their enemies back, the Eurondan Alliance because they didn't want to attack Earth and Etheria, but Jack was sure that left alone, they'd pick up where they had stopped as soon as they thought they could get away with it.

"Incoming transport," Campbell reported.

Ah. The Eurondans were arriving. Finally. And the others were stepping out of the tent to welcome them.

Jack joined them.

"Let's hope they'll be reasonable," Adora commented as she watched the plane transfer from flight to hovering.

"They are reasonable - from their point of view," Daniel pointed out. "They have different standards and customs."

"And they were almost wiped out by the Space Nazis," Jack added. "They don't want to forgive and forget." Which he fully understood. Hell, in their place, he'd feel and want the same.

"And they don't have to. That's what the trial is about," Adora said. "But executing people is wrong."

They had talked about that before. And he disagreed. “Depends on the crime. We executed the Nazis for what they had done.” That was a precedent he could live very well with. And that hadn’t been a miscarriage of justice, either.

“That was fifty years ago,” Daniel retorted. “Since then, most countries have abolished the death penalty.”

“America hasn’t,” Jack replied. The transport had landed, and the door was opening.

“Actually, the Supreme Court had it suspended for a time in the 1970s.”

“And that didn’t last.” Some crimes deserved the death penalty. What the Nazis had done - and the Eurondan Nation here - certainly qualified.

“And that was wrong.” Adora shook her head. “That the United States is the only country in the Alliance with the death penalty still in effect should show you that.”

“We’re kinda bad about following others’ leads,” Jack told her.

“That kind of ‘American exceptionalism’ is not necessarily a good thing,” Daniel, of course, had to say that right before the Eurondans were close enough to overhear any response Jack would have.

So he smiled through the greetings and then followed the others into the tent. At least the food was great again.

The discussion afterwards, though, not so much.

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“...why are you protecting those murderers?”

“We aren’t protecting them. They’ll be tried as you demanded.”

“But you won’t allow us to execute them. You are still trying to deny justice to our dead!”

Jack had to stop himself from nodding along with Lan’s snapped statement. You didn’t stab your own side in the back. Even if you disagreed with them.

“Killing people isn’t justice,” Adora disagreed. “Two wrongs don’t make a right.”

“Shouldn’t the punishment fit the crime?” Liou asked. “You do not treat the thief as you treat the murderer, nor should you treat the murderer as you treat the thief.”

“That doesn’t mean you should kill people.” Adora shook her head. “The death penalty is wrong. Dead people cannot change and become better. Nor can they make up for what they have done. That’s not justice.”

“What those monsters have done is beyond the pale!” Lan thundered. “And even if they wanted to, they could never make up for their crimes - you cannot bring back the dead!”

“Killing them won’t bring back the dead either,” Daniel said.

“But it will give us justice,” Lan retorted.

Sha’re nodded at that, Jack noted.

Daniel didn’t seem to have noticed, though. Or, more likely, he was deliberately ignoring it - Jack was sure that Sha’re had told him what she thought about the death penalty already if in private.

“You’re wrong.” Adora wasn’t moved. “We’re not going to let you kill people just to feel better. That’s wrong.”

She and Lan stared at each other for a moment. Then Lan slowly tilted his head to the side. “That will make it harder for our people

to accept any peace agreement. They have lost too much to forgive easily."

"We're doing what we can to restore what was lost," Adora retorted. "We're going to heal your planet and will help with rebuilding."

"And yet, you will also force us to keep sharing the planet with the people who tried their worst to ruin it and kill us all," Lan said. "It seems as if you're treating them the same as you treat their victims."

Adora frowned, but before she could say anything, Daniel leaned forward. "Is there anything we can do, except for letting you kill or displace people, that would remedy that?"

Lan slowly nodded. "Yes. Without the unprovoked war, without the ruin of our lands, we would have advanced a lot over the last decades. We would have developed better technology and improved our standards of living. All that was lost to us due to the Eugenists. We don't want our world to be merely restored to the status quo, but advanced to the point where we should be."

Ah - they wanted more tech and help as the price for saving the lives of the Space Nazis. A little transparent but not easy to refuse, at least for the Etherians.

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Adora frowned. That was… Well, it sounded logical, but it felt wrong to her. "You want us to 'compensate' you for what the Eurondan nation did to you? Beyond restoring the planet's ecosystem and the artificial wombs we promised you?"

"Yes." Lan nodded firmly.

"Just so you won't commit genocide in revenge or execute criminals?" Best to make sure she had understood them correctly.

“So my people will accept the leniency you demand,” Lan replied. “We have lost too much otherwise.”

“And there’s the question of magic. You unilaterally decided to change our world not just once but twice,” Liou added. “Without consulting us.”

Adora blinked. That was…. “I had to restore magic to allow us to save the Eurondans. And that always comes with a surge of magic power, which I have to direct into something like healing. Otherwise, the risk of magic going out of control and causing potentially catastrophic consequences is too high. In this case, I filtered out the poison and restored life to your world - at least, to a big part of it - with the magic power.”

“I don’t think you can honestly claim you mind this,” Daniel said. “While restoring the world could have been achieved without magic, it would have taken - would take; we’re still not done - a lot longer.”

“But it was done without asking what we thought about it. You decided to add magic to our world for your convenience without caring whether or not we wanted this,” Lan retorted. “That was wrong.”

Adora blushed a little. They were correct - she had acted without thinking about their opinion. She had been sure that what she was doing was right. And it hadn’t been wrong - it had probably been the only way to save the Eurondan Nation’s people from dying. And it had been the best, surely the fastest, way to heal their world, though she had underestimated the difficulty of controlling the magic.

But, yes, she had to admit that she had gone over the heads of pretty much everyone who actually lived on this world. And that wasn’t right. “I’m sorry about that,” she said.

For a moment, no one said anything, as if they waited for her to add something else. Then Lan spoke up. “Saying you’re sorry

doesn’t change what you did - or make up for it.”

“No, it doesn’t.” Adora agreed.

“But trying to get free technology as compensation for getting your world healed just because we didn’t ask you if we should save you is a bit much,” Jack said. “Sounds a bit greedy.”

“Greedy?” Lan glared at him. “My people were almost wiped out! My world was almost ruined! And you want us to accept that those responsible for unspeakable crimes will not be punished according to our laws!”

“Yes.” Adora nodded again. “Because your laws aren’t just.”

“How dare you insult us like this!” Lan stood up to glare at her.

Adora met his eyes. She knew she was right here.

“Genocide, ethnic cleansing, the death penalty - Earth, Etheria and the Eurondan Alliance, we all feel strongly about all of it,” Daniel quickly said with a placating smile. “Very strongly,” he added with a nod to the Eurondans. “But we can discuss this and find common ground.”

“We are talking about millions murdered in cold blood,” Lan spat. “Poisoned and starved, often dying right under the eyes of those who barely survived. If you want us to come to an agreement that will hold, you cannot expect us to bow to your demands without getting anything in return.”

“Not counting your world restored and the war ended,” Jack said.

“Something we would have achieved ourselves without your interference,” Liou countered. “Without your, ah, rivals, our enemies wouldn’t have found resources to continue the war for much longer.”

“We’re also doing what we can to restore your world completely,” Adora said. “And we will listen to you about that.”

"And protect your world against the Goa'uld," Catra spoke up.

"Both goals would be served better if we had the technology to do so ourselves," Liu said. "Allowing you to focus on your own worlds and allies."

Adora shook her head. "We only share that kind of technology with our allies and friends."

"And we don't trust you not to take the technology and then use it against the Eurondan Nation as soon as we're gone from your world," Catra added.

"You doubt our word?" Lan had been about to sit down, or so it had seemed to Adora, but he kept standing and glared at Catra.

Catra, as Adora should have expected, was entirely unimpressed. She shrugged and nodded. "You've made it clear that you answer to your people, so if they think you're too soft, they'll replace you with someone else."

Lan clenched his teeth at that. "That is why we need an agreement that will be accepted by my people."

"And why we need a squadron of frigates in orbit," Catra muttered at Adora's side.

Adora shook her head. This was wrong - they shouldn't use force, or the threat of force, to make the Eurondans agree to their demands. But giving in to their demands wasn't right either.

"Well, I am sure we can reach a compromise," Daniel said. "I doubt you can honestly argue that you would have achieved the technology to build spaceships that can travel to other solar systems if the war hadn't happened. Or our weapon technology. But there are examples of advanced technology we could share. Namely, the artificial wombs we mentioned before. And food production. Construction. Media. We can boost your standard of living significantly."

Adora nodded.

"What exactly are you offering?" Liu asked as Lan sat down again.

Adora smiled and tried not to sigh. This would be tiring. Such negotiations always were. But as long as they reached an agreement in the end that they could live with, it would be worth it.

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Gate Room, Euronda, December 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...so, we'll still share our technology with them as long as it's not weapon technology? Even though they're not in the Alliance?"

Samantha Carter nodded at Entrapta's question. "Within limits. Mostly the artificial wombs and technology to support their reconstruction and agricultural efforts."

Entrapta cocked her head to the side. "Ah. So, nothing really new."

"Not for us," Sam confirmed. "But we have to ensure it cannot be used to develop weapons before we hand anything over." Daniel had been more than a bit hasty in his attempt to continue the negotiations.

"Ah." Her friend pouted for a moment. "That's going to be hard. You can turn a lot of advanced technology into weapons. The artificial wombs could be used to breed creatures that can fight if you repurpose them. And any construction technology can be used to build fortifications. And any bioreactors could probably produce bioweapons instead of food."

Sam suppressed a wince. Entrapta was a great friend and an incredibly nice person. But she also had a sometimes scary talent for building weapons. That she didn't always understand when one should construct weapons and when not didn't help. "They can already grow bioweapons, I think - they must have

bioreactors to feed their people - and they can construct bunkers. New technology would only speed either process up and not add new capabilities. And I don't think we'll have to worry about animals bred for war."

"Are you sure? When I talked with Loki and the others on Alpha about the genetic samples of Eurondan fauna we've sent them, they noticed that we lacked sufficient predators to keep all the fast-breeding herbivore species in check, and they had several ideas about making a few of the animals we do have samples of into more effective predators to compensate, and some of those would make them good at fighting soldiers as well. Like paralysing tentacles and adaptive camouflage. Or glands to produce aerosolised venom."

Maybe Sam shouldn't have focused on expanding the sensor net on Euronda and restring the life support systems in the Eurondan Nation's defence complex for so long. "I don't think the Eurondans have the capability to genetically engineer species to that degree," she said. I sure hope so, she added to herself. "But we will make sure to install safeguards."

"In the artificial wombs? I thought we wanted to let them build them," Entrapta said. "And given the Eurondan Nation's skills with software that we saw after analysing the programs used to hack Stargate Command, and which the Eurondan Alliance should have as well, or they would have lost the war already, right? - I think they would detect any such programs."

"Yes, that wouldn't work," Sam agreed. "But we can monitor the wombs and the Stargate with our scanners. Though I think they will focus on restoring their world before starting another war."

Entrapta looked sceptical. "Are you sure? It would be logical, but people aren't often logical. The Eurondan Alliance don't seem to like us even though we restored most of their world and ended the war."

“We were a bit heavy-handed,” Sam pointed out. “We started altering their world without consulting them. And we returned magic.” And stopped them from finishing off their enemies.

“But we’re helping them! Their world was dead!” Entrapta protested. “And magic is a natural part of their world!”

“Not everyone likes magic,” Sam said. And she couldn’t help suspecting that part of the reason for the way the Eurondan Alliance had reacted was that their leaders weren’t used to dealing with women in positions of authority. Especially young women. But that could just be Sam’s own biases, based on her experiences on Earth, influencing her.

“That’s stupid.” Entrapta pouted. “That’s like not liking science.”

Sam agreed, though she was aware that many students didn’t like science, at least in school. And the less said about the religious zealots on Earth and their issues with science (and logic and reality itself), the better. “Yes, it is. But that’s what the Eurondan Alliance thinks about it.” Or claimed to think - the General was quite convinced that a significant part of the Eurondan Alliance’s complaints were just to support their negotiations. “Anyway,” she went on, “we’re supposed to go over what kind of technology we can safely share with the Eurondan Alliance to help them recover.”

“Hm. We need to know what they already can do,” Entrapta said. “So we can cover the gaps.”

Sam almost snorted at the thought of asking Lan about their technology and how the man would react. “Even if they already have the technology, their production capacity is almost assuredly very limited, so providing them with tools and machines would still be very helpful.” And, a cynical part of her added in the back of her mind, it would allow some of Earth’s industry to offload soon-to-be-obsolete products on the Alliance’s pay.

“Right!” Entrapta nodded. “And we can check with our scanners where they have the worst deficits.”

That was essentially spying on the Eurondan Alliance, but Sam didn't mind doing it if it helped them reach an agreement. They would be spying on the Eurondan Alliance anyway to ensure that they would not attempt to restart the war.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 20th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"Why do we care what those Eurondans want, anyway? We saved their planet, and as thanks, they make demands of us? We should just finish fixing their planet and then leave!"

Frosta had a point, in Catra's opinion. Not that she would ever say so, of course. And the princess was still wrong, anyway.

"We can't! If we leave, the Eurondan Alliance will kill the Eurondan Nation's people!" Adora blurted out.

"Then we evacuate them to another planet," Frosta retorted. "They tried to kill the Eurondan Alliance first, and almost succeeded, so they can't complain about having to move."

"That wouldn't be right either," Adora told her. "Ethnic cleansing is wrong."

"And it would put a strain on our logistics," Mermista added. "We couldn't just drop them on another planet - if we find one, anyway - without any infrastructure. Even if we limit our investment to the bare minimum for them to live, we're talking about building an entire country from scratch - including transportation and industry."

"If we use the Tok'ra's technology, we could quickly build up underground bases for everyone," Entrapta cut in. "That would be much faster than building on the surface. And we could duplicate their bioreactors to produce food." She looked at her multitool. "That wouldn't be a heavy strain on our logistics, actually."

Adora looked taken aback for a moment.

Frosta nodded with a smile: “That would leave them like they were during the war. They’re used to that.”

Oh, for…! Catra snorted. “And you think they’ll change like that? No matter how good their new planet might be, they’d still prefer their own world. And they’ll blame us for losing their world.” And without any help and support, they would be stuck living as if they were still at war for a long, long time. That kind of life would only make them even worse.

“So?” Frosta shrugged and narrowed her eyes. “They started the war.”

Catra clenched her teeth. She knew what the princess was hinting at. The Horde had started a war as well. But…

“And we ended the war,” Adora said, frowning at Frosta. “We can’t turn our back on them. They need our help - both the Eurondan Nation and the Eurondan Alliance.”

“Then they should act like it! Show some gratitude!” Frosta snapped.

“They’re trying to milk us,” Glimmer added.

“We did act a bit… high-handed, I think,” Bow said.

“Yes,” Adora agreed.

“We didn’t have much choice,” Glimmer retorted. “And we did the right thing. They’re trying to make us reward them with the threat of sinking as low as their enemies did. And that is not acceptable!”

“But we need to help them!” Perfuma protested. “Without our help, it’ll be decades, possibly centuries, before their world’s ecology recovers.”

“We will help them.” Adora shook her head. “But we can’t just leave them be, or they’ll never change for the better.”

“We can’t exactly make them change,” Mermista said.

Catra wasn’t so sure about that. There were ways to change a culture - the Horde had done that to the Scorpion Kingdom. Even now, the new Scorpion Kingdom was very different from the kingdom that Scorpia’s ancestors had ruled. It was heavily influenced by the Horde survivors living there. So much, Catra wouldn’t want to live there - she would constantly be reminded of her past.

“That’s another reason why we shouldn’t force the Eurondan Nation off their world; if they learn to live together, they’ll change. Both sides,” Glimmer said.

If, Catra thought.

“So, we’ll bribe them with our tech?” Mermista asked. “And station a task force there to make them play nice with each other, all for their own benefit?”

“Essentially, yes,” Adora told her. “If we share our technology, they can rebuild on their own. Mostly - we still need to help with restoring their world’s biosphere.”

“And Earth will support them with tools, machines and other stuff that is going obsolete but will still work perfectly fine,” Bow added.

Perfuma nodded. “That’s a good thing - otherwise, they would probably throw away all those things, and that would cause a lot of environmental damage.” She frowned. “Earth really should stop being so wasteful.”

“That’s how they do things,” Mermista said with a shrug. “Anyway, what about the proposal for tomorrow’s meeting?”

Adora frowned a little - she was in charge of the meeting, and Catra knew that her lover didn’t like it when others tried to do her

job for her - but nodded. "Yes. We've collected a list of supplies and technology that we think can be safely sent to Euronda. Mostly old agricultural and industrial tools and machinery from Earth and our artificial womb technology. We'll have to build the wombs first, though, until the Eurondans can build their own."

"And what about magic?" Scorpia asked.

Adora winced.

Glimmer scowled. "We don't have enough teachers for our allies; we surely can't spare them for the Eurondans."

Catra agreed, though she was sure that the Eurondans wouldn't like that. Although she wouldn't put it past them to be glad that no 'foreigner' tried to teach them how to work magic on their world. Actually, that would be a good way to make them refuse such an offer - make it patronisingly enough, and Lan would probably refuse out of principle just to avoid more 'foreign meddling'.

Which brought up another question. "What about religion?" Catra asked. If the task force sent there came from Third Fleet - and they were closer than Second and First Fleet - then that meant Priest would send his best, so to speak.

Adora grimaced. "I'll tell them that they can't proselytise."

Everyone nodded, but Catra was sure it wouldn't help much. Priest was good at getting around such orders. Probably by avoiding open proselytising but having the Clones 'honestly answer questions' or something like that.

And then Adora would frown but accept it.

*****

Restored Zone, Main Continent, Euronda, December 21st, 1999 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill was really sick of these meetings. To think a few of his fellow generals, and a number of people from the State Department, were complaining about him 'involving himself with diplomatic ventures that aren't the concern of the military'! It wasn't as if he *wanted* to meddle in these affairs.

But he wasn't about to leave it all to the Etherians and Daniel. They were both a bit too idealistic and a bit too… nice was a good word, in Jack's opinion. Sometimes, you had to be a bastard if you wanted to do your job as a leader. Every officer worth their salt learned that. And Jack would rather take that role than foist it on any of his friends.

And he had grown to dislike the Eurondan Alliance. At least their diplomats. They weren't as bad as the Eurondan Nation, not that that was hard since Alar's bunch were genocidal Space Nazis. But Lan was, as Cambell had put it, 'a right sort of prick', and Liou was far too smooth and smug for Jack's taste.

Sure, they had more than enough reasons to want the Space Nazis gone - something Jack agreed with - but the way they went about it was annoying. It was as if they were using their dead as arguments to get more technology. Like selling out, in a way. If they couldn't get justice, then money would do nicely.

"Let's hope they never meet an ambulance chaser," he muttered as he studied the horizon.

"Hm?" Catra made a questioning sound next to him.

"Nothing," Jack replied. "Just thinking out loud."

"Mh."

They stared at the hills in the distance in silence for a bit. Then Carter reported that the Alliance transport was approaching, and Jack sighed. Time to deal with the pricks again.

And to try to ignore all the 'concerns' and 'suggestions' he had heard in all the meetings he had had to attend back on Earth

when he should have been taking care of his unit instead. It was kind of fitting that actual combat missions and operations didn't draw a tenth of the attention from that crowd compared to the hint of potential profit for their lobbyists.

On the other hand, that was actually a good thing. If they tried to interfere with the war, it would be a debacle.

*****

"Those designs do not look very advanced. We had similar machines before the war," Liou complained.

"They aren't advanced at all, so your people won't need a lot of training to use them."

Jack O'Neill grinned at Glimmer's reply. It was evasive and misleading but technically correct. "We can't exactly send an army of instructors while we're waging a war against body-snatching aliens," he added. "We need them ourselves." Hell, sparing the ships and Clones to watch over the planet and keep the Eurodans from genociding each other would already be a bit of a strain. Tough just a little bit, as long as the Alliance didn't actually occupy the planet. That would be a mess.

"So you foist your outdated equipment on us?" Lan scoffed.

"You can use it, can't you?" Glimmer's smile showed all her teeth.

"We could use more advanced machinery as well," Liou retorted. He made a point of looking at Emily standing guard in the back. "Especially if they were autonomous."

"You'd have trouble maintaining, much less replacing them," Jack said.

"They look rather rugged. By the time they would need replacement, I think we would have learned how to maintain and build them." Liou smiled. "Our weapons are more advanced than the tools you offer, after all."

“As I said, we need the advanced technology ourselves,” Jack repeated himself before Entrapta could offer to build some agricultural bots that not even Etheria had yet.

“So you say,” Lan said. “Yet you can spare the time and supplies to save our enemies.”

“And your world,” Glimmer said. “We prioritise saving lives.”

Daniel nodded. “And with your war won, you can focus on rebuilding. You won’t need to concentrate on military industry any more.”

Lan scoffed. “With an Empire of hostile aliens waiting in the skies, who, as you told us, would turn us into primitive, uneducated slaves? We need advanced weapons more than ever!”

“We’ll station a task force in your system to protect you,” Adora told him.

“And what if that’s not enough to defend our world?” Liou asked.

Glimmer shrugged. “Even if we handed over all our technology to you, by the time you could manage to build enough spaceships and advanced weapons to actually make a difference, the war will likely be over.”

Lan ground his teeth at that, but Glimmer was right. Earth, with magnitudes more industrial potential and people, was already struggling to catch up. Euronda wouldn’t meaningfully contribute to the war against the Goa’uld in time to matter. Not even if, by some miracle, all the survivors on both sides decided to unite and work together with all their might.

Of course, they couldn’t be trusted anyway.

“That seems optimistic,” Liou said. “Wars rarely go according to plan, as our enemies found out. Wouldn’t it be wise to at least have contingency plans in case your war will last for several decades?”

“Yes,” Glimmer told him with another toothy smile. “But if the war lasts for so long, then the last thing we would want was to send your people to the frontlines. You already suffered so much and barely survived your own war.”

“We could still provide you with war materials if we had an automated industry set up.”

“Oh, we can do that ourselves,” Entrapta cut in with a wide and honest smile. “We’ve been working on automated production facilities, like for our spy bots. Don’t worry about that. In the long term, our main bottleneck is manpower, though, in a pinch, we can ramp up cloning, I guess.”

The Eurondans didn’t like hearing that. Not at all. Hell, Jack wasn’t sure he liked it, though for different reasons - more Clones? Or, even worse, cloning humans? That was a can of worms he’d rather shoot into the sun.

Adora nodded. “So, thank you for your offer, but we won’t burden you with such demands. You can focus on rebuilding your world with our help.”

Her smile wasn’t as smug as Catra’s, Jack noted, but she was clearly - at least in his impression - at least a little glad to tell off the Eurondans.

As was he. Though not as much as he was relieved that with this done, he could finally focus back on his actual job.

*****

Holiday Season Part 1

Gate Zone, Euronda, December 22nd, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, you have sold us out."

Adora wanted to sigh and roll her eyes at Alar's words, but that would have been… not appropriate for the occasion. Which didn't stop Catra from doing exactly that, of course, but Adora was She-Ra, and she had to maintain her dignity. This was, after all, an official meeting. And she had to set a good example for the Alliance soldiers guarding the gate room and the rest of the defence complex. Even though, or perhaps especially, since most of them belonged to Jack's command.

So she slowly nodded instead of telling Alar that they didn't owe him anything in the first place. "Yes. We've finished a treaty with the Eurondan Alliance. In exchange for various concessions from the Alliance against the Goa'uld, represented by us, and the complete disarmament of the Eurondan Nation, they have agreed to end the war with the Eurondan Nation without forcing you off-world. They have also agreed that the death penalty will not be available in the trials of suspected war criminals. Trials which will be conducted by a mixed court with judges from the Eurondan Alliance and the Alliance against the Goa'uld."

Alar looked relieved for a moment - had he expected them to sacrifice his life to placate the Eurondan Alliance? But he quickly scowled and sounded even more defiant. "We fought a war. You kill your enemies in war. If what we did was wrong, then so was what the Breeders did."

Adora narrowed her eyes at him. "You don't murder civilians - not even in a war! That's a law that applies to everyone." She walked up to him and leaned forward, looming over him. "You attempted a *genocide*!"

Alar cringed, taking a half-step back, but then straightened. “We struck at our enemies! If we hadn’t struck first, they would have attacked us sooner or later under a pretext to erase us and our culture!”

“Come on, save this for the judges,” Jack said. “They might buy it.”

Alar glared at him. “As if the judgement wasn’t decided already!”

“You’ll get a fair trial,” Daniel told him. “We've had such trials before, trust us. We’ll ensure that you receive a skilled defender and that everything follows procedure.”

“Your laws and procedure!” Alar shook his head. “Why bother with this farce? We all know how this will play out.”

“That’s how we do things,” Jack said with bared teeth. “Even genocidal Space Nazis get their day in court.”

Daniel cleared his throat. “Well, it’s not as cut and dried as you claim. If you weren’t in a position of authority - if you had no part in the decision to launch a genocidal attack against the Eurondan Alliance - then you will not be held responsible for that. There are many precedents in our history. We don’t punish people for merely waging war.”

“So, you come and crush us, hand our enemies the victory in our war, and then expect us to be grateful to you for not letting the Breeders murder or exile every one of us?” Alar scoffed, but he sounded closer to crying. “What did we do to you to deserve this?”

“Well, for starters, you supplied our enemies with weapons to attack us,” Jack said with a shrug. “We take a dim view of such things. And then we found out that you tried to murder everyone on your world who disagreed with your customs. That’s kind of a red flag for us. That you also ruined your planet is kind of just gravy.”

Adora nodded. The Eurondan Alliance was annoying with their wheedling and demanding more concessions - though Adora and her friends had stayed mostly firm and wouldn't hand over weapon technology, magitech, or advanced aerospace technology - but they hadn't started this war. Or tried to kill her friends. "We'll take you and the others on the list in custody now."

"But… that will leave our people leaderless!"

"I'm sure someone else will step up and take over," Jack said. "They've probably been preparing for that ever since they heard the news from us. It's kind of what Nazis do."

Alar shook his head but didn't say anything else. Not even when two soldiers stepped up to him and cuffed him before leading him to the Stargate. He and the others would be held in a prison on Earth, to keep them safe from revenge.

Jack watched him go and sighed. "We really should install a democracy here. If we let them continue with their system, they won't change."

"We're not here to force your system on them," Glimmer disagreed. "Or ours," she added. "We're just here to stop them from destroying each other and their world."

"Then this won't be peace but just an armistice for twenty years," Jack retorted.

"We'll see." Adora knew people could change. And the Eurondans had to change, anyway, to adapt to the end of the war and the restoration of their world. "At least they won't have to fight a war any more. Both the Eurondan Nation and the Eurondan Alliance can now focus on rebuilding their countries in peace."

"Lan didn't act like it," Glimmer pointed out. "He kept trying to get more weapon technology from us. What did he think, that we would give him more weapons so he could launch an attack on the Eurondan Nation as soon as we turn our back to them?"

Daniel cleared his throat again. "I don't think it's that - or just that, I suppose. The Eurondan Alliance was fighting for their lives for decades, knowing that if they lost, it would be the end for their entire people, culture and history. That kind of conflict would have shaped their Society. It's quite understandable that they will want to arm up until they feel they can fend off any attacker."

"We will protect them. We told them so," Adora said.

"But they don't trust us. Which is also understandable - from their point of view, we protected their enemies," Daniel said. "It will take time for them to come to terms with the situation."

"Whatever!" Glimmer scoffed. "Let's leave now. We've ended the war and restored most of their world. That's enough."

It wasn't, not really. There was so much still wrong in this world. But they had far more worlds to save than this one, worlds far worse off than this one, too.

And they hadn't finished restoring the world's biosphere yet. But that was not something Adora could help with.

"Yes, let's go."

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 23rd, 1999

Samantha Carter watched as yet another transport carrying a standard freight container drove up the ramp of the Stargate. The transport used an electric drive - the ventilation of the base could have handled the exhausts from internal combustion engines, but it would have been an additional strain on the system, and the engines could just be hooked up to the base's reactors to be recharged, which was both easier and safer than refuelling outside or transporting more fuel into the base. Less fuel meant a lessened fire risk - something she could appreciate after her visit to Euronda.

Even with the additional security added after the attack by the Russians and Chinese, the whole process went smoothly - as one transport drove through the gate and vanished, the next one lined up behind it. Optimising the gate schedule for efficiency and costs, taking into account the space available for parking and storage and leaving enough windows for other gate missions - both planned and unplanned, was a challenge, but the best logisticians of the planet were working on it and had it down to science.

Sam had checked. Just in case. There wouldn't be another sabotage attempt on her watch. And this was an Alliance mission, anyway.

"Carter! There you are!"

She turned around and straightened. The General had arrived! "Sir. I thought you were expected in Washington." She had checked his schedule, as usual. She wasn't his Second-in-Command any more, but old habits died slowly.

"Ah, the meeting had to be cancelled so the general responsible could do his Christmas shopping." He grinned, and Sam couldn't tell if he was serious or not.

So she nodded. "I see."

"So, I decided to check up on our latest deployments," he went on. "Make sure everything's alright on our favourite new planet."

She frowned at that. With the holidays coming up, and after he had been absent for so long from his command to deal with the Eurondans, the paperwork must have been piling up on his desk.

He snorted. "I'm up to date on paperwork, Major."

She managed not to blush; he knew her too well after years of working together so closely. "Of course, sir."

“I’ve got actual aides for that, you know? Perks of being a general.”

“Yes, sir.”

“Anyway, I’m just going to hitch a ride on the next transport for a surprise inspection.” He hesitated a moment. “Want to tag along and check up on the restoration stuff?”

She was tempted. Only to check that the team headed by Perfuma didn’t need any technical assistance, of course. They were supposed to call either Entrapta, Sam or Bow if they had trouble with the bots helping them deploy the next wave of plants. The animals were still being cloned in Alpha, but the first batch would be ready before the new year.

But she had her own tasks to deal with - and she didn’t have an aide to handle her paperwork. So, she sighed softly and shook her head. “I’ll have to pass, sir.”

“Alright. See you in an hour or so?”

By then, she would still be here, handling the bits of advanced technology they were shipping to the Eurondan Alliance. “Yes, sir.”

He smiled, waved, and then stepped forward as the next transport drove up to the ramp. As soon as the transport stopped for the go-ahead from the traffic controller, the General opened the door and slid inside with smooth grace befitting a man twenty years younger.

She suppressed a sigh and turned back to her scanner. The artificial wombs were not yet ready - construction facilities had still to be set up, and since several countries were very interested in hosting those, and even more in the products, things had been delayed a bit. But the advanced bioreactors they had promised the Erondans to increase their food production were ready; Priest had delivered a few spare units from Third Fleet. He had also sent a team of Clones to install them and instruct the Eurondans in their use - and to spread the word of She-Ra or something on the

sly. Not that Sam really cared. A number of Eurondans converting might make handling the whole planet easier, especially if people from both sides converted. On the other hand, that might create the first schism in the Church of She-Ra…

But that was a problem for Priest and Adora. And probably Daniel. Sam had to ensure that the safety features on the bioreactors were intact. No one wanted the Eurondans to use the reactors to manufacture bioweapons. Not after seeing first-hand what Alar's people had done to their world.

But so far, all the systems checked out. She signed the forms for this batch and then watched as they were packed into containers. As they were loaded on the next transport, she noticed General Hammond walking toward her.

"General."

"Major." He smiled. "Everything alright?"

"Yes, sir."

"I guess I missed General O'Neill?"

Sam nodded. "He just went through the gate, sir."

"Ah. Well, I can ask you, I think."

She wasn't in the General's chain of command any more, not officially. But she probably could answer what question General Hammond had anyway. "Yes, sir?"

"Will SG-1 - well, the former SG-1 - attend Stargate Command's New Year's Party?"

Ah. Sam blinked. Right. The holiday season meant parties. Christmas and New Year's parties. With the Eurondan Affair, she hadn't even thought about that. And neither had her friends, she suspected. "I don't know yet," she said. A safe answer.

"Well, you're certainly invited." General Hammond beamed at her. "We all owe you for saving our bacon once again."

"Thank you, sir."

Sam was already trying to remember which parties she could miss and which she couldn't. Between the General and her Etherian friends, she probably wouldn't be able to skip as many as she would prefer. But she knew she didn't want to miss Stargate Command's New Year's Party. That was a tradition, after all. Even if she had been dragged to most of them in the past.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, December 24th, 1999

"It almost looks like we're on Earth," Catra commented as she walked at Adora's side towards the palace gates.

Adora looked around, frowning a little in that cute way of hers, then shook her head. "On Earth, the whole street would be decked out in Christmas decorations. Not just a few shops."

It was more than a few shops, actually - about every third shop was sporting tinsel and green and red ribbons or plants. And all of those shops had displays like on Earth. "Close enough," she said.

Adora nodded. "It looks like we missed a big smuggling ring."

"Those aren't wares from Earth," Catra corrected her lover. "Those are *'Earth-style goods'*. Copies made here." One of the shops even advertised as that. Although she had no doubt that the shop would sell actual contraband under the table if the owner had access to a smuggler. Not to them, of course - the clerks would know that Adora would report them. But if Catra were alone… Hm.

"Well, it's only natural," Adora said. "Earth media are very popular, and people watching the shows and movies will see a lot of Earth

products. Of course, they'll be curious about them. Daniel said similar things happen on Earth all the time."

Catra knew that Etherian goods would fetch a premium on Earth - and did whenever someone managed to smuggle something through the Stargate, though that would be even rarer after they had improved security. But she'd never seen - or heard of - a similar 'Etherian-style goods' fad. "What does Glimmer think about this?" she asked as they passed a bakery with 'original French croissants' that looked pretty similar to the ones she had eaten in Paris.

Adora winced a little. "Ah, she said she wanted to look into encouraging local businesses."

"So, she's not happy with everyone being crazy for Earth stuff." Catra snorted. She could understand that - if she were a princess, she would be a bit worried about that as well.

"It's not that," Adora said. "It's the whole difference between our population and Earth's. That's why the trade deals are stalled as well."

"Well, duh." Catra scoffed. "If we opened trade, the Stargate would be blocked for years with all the stuff Earth would ship to us." Most of it junk or obsolete stuff, but it would still sell.

"Yes. But they are pushing - and complaining about, well, that." Adora pointed at a shop advertising Earth media and assorted merchandise. "They still want us to 'respect copyright'."

"Good luck with that." Catra shook her head. Etheria didn't work like that.

"Some of the princesses were debating whether or not they should agree," Adora said. "But mostly because the don't like Earth media being so popular and think by cracking down on smuggling, it would become more expensive and less common."

Catra snorted. That wasn't how things worked. You couldn't stop smuggling, not even the Horde had managed, and media wasn't bottlenecked by the Stargate's capacity. You could transport a whole library on a single memory crystal.

"Mermista didn't think it would work either," Adora said.

"She would know." Both from Sea Hawk and her experience with smuggling on the sea. "Well, it's not our problem," Catra said. She narrowed her eyes at Adora to remind her lover of that.

"I know!" Adora blushed a little. "Though cultural exchange is."

Catra rolled her eyes. That again! The Asgard's visit had been bad enough, and Earth's would be worse - a lot of Etherians were crazy for Earth culture, especially their artists. "You'll have to assign a company or more for crowd control once the stars arrive," she said.

"That's up to the ruling princesses," Adora said. "Not all of them were, ah, enthusiastic."

"I bet they're just jealous they are less popular than Earth artists." Catra grinned.

Adora cleared her throat and didn't comment.

Catra's grin widened. "Well, you don't have that problem. You're the most popular princess. Here and on Earth."

That earned her a frown. "I don't care. I just… oh, no!"

Catra quickly followed her lover's gaze. "Oh!" She chuckled. "Priest must have taken notes."

In front of another shop, three Clones stood in a booth with a life-sized cardboard cutout of She-Ra, sword raised and shining with blinding light. Next to it, they had placed a box for donations and stacks of flyers, books and crystals. "It's really like Christmas on Earth. Be glad they didn't dress you up as Santa," she said.

Adora muttered a curse under her breath.

"Cheer up - it means Etheria has at least one celebrity who's popular in the rest of the Alliance," Catra told her with a snicker.

"I'd rather see Sea Hawk become a star on Earth with his shanties," Adora snapped.

Catra laughed as they took a detour so they wouldn't pass in front of the stall. Then she frowned as she had another thought. "If they're doing that on Earth, that could cause trouble." Earth took their weird religions seriously, and it was holiday season for the Alliance.

Adora sighed.

*****

Pentagon, Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, December 24th, 1999

"That's very interesting, General. I'll be sure to keep that in mind when we're training in Germany."

As an example of how not to conduct a landing operation on another planet, Jack O'Neill added to himself when he turned away to refill his glass. That was an insane proposal, and from a fellow Air Force officer to boot! Really, it sounded as if the man had never considered that a planetary invasion was focused on securing the *orbitals*. You couldn't establish air superiority if the enemy could bomb you from space no matter how daringly you dropped on the planet. And if you had control of the orbitals, you did the same to the enemy.

With people like that working at the Pentagon, it was no wonder that the Navy pukes had won the battle for the US space forces!

Besides, Jack ran Alliance Special Forces Command, not the Space Marines. He wasn't in charge of invading planets, he was in charge of taking out key objectives for invasions, running ops

behind enemy lines, search and rescue and all the fun stuff SG-1 had gotten up to in their days.

His glass refilled with excellent whisky - the Pentagon didn't skimp on food and drinks for their general staff mixers - he made his way to the corner of the room closest to the door. He had been here for almost an hour; it was time to slip out as soon as the opportunity presented itself. Before he drank too much and started to hurt some of the idiots here.

Like Admiral Kearsy. Jack hadn't forgotten the debriefing of the Saqqara mission. The man was talking to the Secretary of Defense near the other end of the bar. Jack considered cutting in if only to see if he had to heed off another blatant powerplay by the Navy to cripple the funding for the rest of the branches so they could design another death trap to show off the limeys.

He decided against it. If the Navy tried anything, it would go through Alliance Command, and Adora would inform him. And they could get Carter to dissect the latest issues with the Navy's ship design.

At least the British ships were coming along according to schedule. If the Navy pukes kept messing up their homebrewed all-in-one-designs, the Marines might be ferried to the first landing zones on British transports escorted by British corvettes.

Which wouldn't be all that bad, actually, in Jack's opinion.

"General O'Neill!"

Damn! Jack forced himself to smile. "General Naird."

"I was wondering if you knew if Major Carter was going to attend this mixer."

Jack narrowed his eyes. Why did Naird want to speak to Carter? At a mixer? The man was married! "Unfortunately, she is busy with critical work for the war." Also known as doing science with Entrapta instead of suffering here with him.

“Oh.” The man’s face fell. “I was hoping to discuss a few things I discovered. As you certainly know, I was assigned to command our Space Signals Corps, and since that relies heavily on the spy bot network Major Carter and Princess Entrapta have developed…” He trailed off with a hopeful smile.

Jack was tempted to mention that ‘Space Signals Corps’ basically was just handling the interface with said network. But everyone knew that, even Naird. And it was Christmas Eve. So he shrugged. “I can’t help you there - I just push the button on the radio. And if it doesn’t work, I call Carter.”

“Err, yes, that’s basically the problem. It works, but we - that is, my command - don’t have the capability to fix anything if it doesn’t work. My aide and my technical advisor have, therefore, formulated a plan for a backup system in case the main network is damaged.”

Ah. Tech talk. “Oh, just mail her your proposal. She will get back to you.”

“We did. Two weeks ago.” Naird pouted. “But we haven’t heard back.”

Really? “Well, I can’t speak for Major Carter, but between the attack by Russia and China and then the mess with the Space Nazis, I think she might have been a bit too busy to give your proposal the attention it deserves.”

“Ah. Maybe I should send a reminder.” Naird nodded.

“Yes.” That wouldn’t endear him to Carter, but that wasn’t Jack’s problem. On the other hand… “Or I could do it. Communications are a critical part of modern warfare, after all, and it’s always good to have backup systems. In fact, I think I’ll go call her right now. Merry Christmas!”

“Ah…” Naird opened his mouth, but Jack was already finishing his drink on the way out.

An excuse to leave the mixer early and to call Carter? That was almost a Christmas present in his book.

But just as he reached the door, it was opened by a concerned-looking captain - Air Force, Jack noted - whose eyes widened when she saw him. "General O'Neill! Captain Brown. We've got a situation."

Damn. Well, he hadn't heard any sirens, so it couldn't be too bad.

"There was an altercation involving several Clones and Alliance soldiers."

Scratch that thought.

*****

"So, fill me in?" Jack O'Neill asked a minute later as they walked through the hallway - toward the exit leading to the landing pads, he noted.

"At the Christmas Party at the Washington Navy Yard, a religious dispute occurred between a group of Clones and Navy personnel. The dispute escalated to violence," Brown replied. "All involved are now either in lockup or in the hospital."

A brawl between Clones and Navy pukes? So, none of his people were involved? "And I was the only general available, I guess?" he half-joked.

"The Supreme Commander is not on Earth nor on duty. The leader of Third Fleet was already informed, and Admiral Brown-Emerson requested your presence since you are on location."

"Ah." That explained why Jack was left holding the bag. Not because he was already in Washington, of course - Priest could probably arrive faster at the Naval Yard from orbit than Jack could make it through Washington D.C.'s traffic. But Jack was a close friend of Adora and so the wily Brit probably figured he could

handle Priest. Well, he wasn't entirely wrong. Jack certainly could think of worse officers being involved in this.

He narrowed his eyes at the thought. "Was Admiral Kearsy informed?" He was the ranking US Navy officer on the council. And he was in Washington as well.

"I don't know. I received a direct call from Admiral Brown-Emerson and immediately went to fetch you, sir. Should I call him?"

"Let him enjoy the party," Jack said as they left the building. "Ever flown in a shuttle?"

"Yes, sir."

"Ever flown in a stealth shuttle?"

"No, sir."

"It's like a shuttle, but better." He grinned again. "Although we won't be using the stealth generator this time."

"Yes, sir."

Jack refrained from making a comment on being too formal. The captain wasn't one of his people. And when working in the Pentagon as a junior officer, especially as a young woman, it was better to be as formal as possible when interacting with your superior.

"Strap in," he told her as they boarded the shuttle, followed by the bot guarding it - the encrypted locks on the shuttle had been built by Carter and Entrapta, but you couldn't be too careful with your personal stealth shuttle around other generals. Doubly so in Washington.

He quickly ran through the pre-flight checks. "So, how bad are the injuries? And how much alcohol was involved?"

“None of the injuries were reported as life-threatening, sir,” Brown replied. “No alcohol was served at the party.”

Jack snorted. “Blood checks on all.”

“Yes, sir.” She made a note on her pad while Jack informed air traffic control of his flight

As soon as he got the clearance, he took off. Five minutes later - mostly because he had to avoid a police chopper - they touched down at the Naval Yard. Next to another shuttle with familiar markings. Third Fleet.

Jack was pretty sure he knew who had arrived with that shuttle.

He was proven right five minutes later when they reached the area where the uninjured participants of the brawl were held in detention. “Hello, Priest. Lieutenant.” He nodded at the Navy officer next to Priest.

“General O’Neill!” The Clone smiled at him. “Merry Christmas, and may Her Divine Highness’s grace bless you as well. And to you,” he added with a nod at Brown.

Ah. Jack was starting to get an inkling of the reasons for the brawl. “Thanks, I guess,” he replied.

“Sir.” The Lieutenant looked as tense as you’d expect from anyone in his position - Priest commanded a fleet with enough firepower to turn Earth into a wasteland, after all.

“So, I heard a couple of people got into a brawl at a party,” Jack said. “I guess someone broke out the booze early.”

“We’re still investigating,” the Lieutenant said. “NCIS was informed. A special agent is on the way.”

“NCIS? Really? Do you do that every time there’s a drunken brawl?” Jack raised his eyebrows. Someone was escalating. Sure, technically, this could be worth a criminal investigation, but

generally, people didn't want to escalate from a disciplinary matter to a criminal one. Especially if it involved foreign service personnel. It looked like someone was playing games here. Wait - he had his own special agent on call. Sort of. "I guess we'll cooperate on this, then."

"Sir?" The Lieutenant looked confused for a moment.

"In investigating this," Jack said. "I'll call my team."

"Special Agents Wilkinson and Paris?" Priest smiled.

The Clone was well-informed. Jack reminded himself not to underestimate him. Religious fanatics could be quite subtle and sly. "Yes. I guess this is straight down their alley. They can talk shop with their colleagues from NCIS."

"Third Fleet will, of course, lend any assistance you need," Priest said.

At least he didn't offer to add his own people to the team. Good. If Jack could keep this from escalating further, he should be able to settle things without too much trouble.

"So, what exactly happened?" Jack asked. "Getting into a brawl on Christmas Eve isn't exactly in the spirit of the holiday, is it?"

"We're still investigating, sir," the Lieutenant replied stiffly. Stalling?

Jack cocked his head. "Exactly. And what do you have so far?"

"We're waiting for NCIS, sir."

Someone really wanted to escalate this. But who? "Let me call my investigative team, then," Jack said. And inform them that they were his investigative team, of course.

He'd get to the bottom of this. And if anyone was playing games involving Third Fleet, he'd take them down. Some things were off-

limits. Especially during a war.

*****

Washington Naval Yard, United States of America, Earth, December 24th, 1999

"No, that's alright. Merry Christmas, Agent Paris!"

"Merry Christmas, General."

Jack O'Neill sighed as he switched off his comm. Apparently, Wilkinson and Paris both had plans for Christmas Eve. He could have pushed - not quite ordered; they were still ironing out how exactly the two would officially fit into his command; the FBI was proving a bit obstructive - but he hadn't. Getting his own special agents would have been a nice way to show up the NCIS special agent, but Jack didn't really think he'd need them to settle a drunken brawl. He'd let the Navy pukes ruin their own holidays instead.

Besides, he might not have two special agents on the way, but he was in charge of Alliance Special Forces Command. That gave him a lot of clout. Hell, if the Navy felt uppity, he could just mention, casually, that the shuttles assigned to his unit had more firepower than the entire Navy, at least until they managed to convert their squadrons to space fighters. Of course, Priest had an actual fleet in orbit…

"So, when will you let me talk to my men? I was under the impression that anyone detained in your country had the right to arrange legal representation and contact their embassy if they were a foreigner," Priest asked.

"I'm sorry, sir, but I don't have the authority to decide that. That is under the purview of the NCIS special agent assigned to this case," the Lieutenant in charge of the detention area replied.

Jack suppressed a snort at the officer's expression. You had to be a screw-up or terribly unlucky to get assigned to this post on

Christmas Eve, and he wondered which was it here. “And when will the special agent arrive?” Jack asked, leaning forward and putting his hands on the man’s desk.

“He’s on his way,” the Lieutenant replied. But traffic is bad at this time of day.”

“We can fetch him with a shuttle,” Priest offered at once. “Just give us his location.”

“Ah… that’s… not my call, sir,” the Lieutenant not-quite-stammered.

Jack frowned. Someone must have given him instructions to stall. But who?

“What’s going on here?”

Ah. Jack had his answer. Probable answer, at least. He smiled - politely - as he turned. “And good evening to you, Admiral Kearsy. Fancy meeting you here.”

The Admiral gave him the barest of nods. “I came as soon as I was informed that there was an incident involving my men.”

“You could have called us, Admiral. We would have sent a shuttle to pick you up.” Priest beamed at him.

“Or you could have flown with me,” Jack added. It was a good thing that Brown wasn’t here, or Kearsy would probably try to blame her.

“Whatever. What’s the status?” Kearsy barked, glaring at the Lieutenant.

“We’re waiting on the NCIS, sir.” the young man looked even more nervous.

“NCIS? Who called them?”

“That’s standard procedure, sir. Especially if it involves foreign soldiers.”

Kearsy scoffed. “That’s a waste of time. Why run an investigation when the results won’t matter?”

Jack narrowed his eyes. “Really? What are you insinuating, Admiral?”

Kearsy scoffed again. “As if you have to ask. No matter what they did, your aliens won’t be punished. Politics will ensure that!”

“I can assure you that my people will be punished for any rules they broke, Admiral,” Priest said. “Whether they actually broke any rules in the first place has yet to be determined, of course.”

“Punished by you.” Kearsy shook his head.

“With Her Divine Highness’s permission, of course,” Priest said. “We all follow her command. If she desires differently, then we shall obey.”

“The United States Navy is not in the habit of idolatry!” Kearsy spat.

Damn! Jack clenched his teeth. What was this fool thinking? Was he drunk? The last thing Jack - or Earth - needed was Priest starting a brawl because an idiot insulted Adora. Or a crusade.

But Priest smiled. “I was talking about the fact that as officers of the Alliance against the Goa’uld, we both answer to the Supreme Commander of said Alliance, Admiral. Though, as far as I am aware, the United States Navy is, like the United States as a country, not beholden to any religion, so I do not quite understand why you are stating the obvious. Even if a majority of your soldiers should decide to follow Her Divine Highness’s teachings, that would not change. Our church perfectly understands and supports this policy.”

"You…" Whatever Kearsy had been about to say, he managed to stop himself.

"Yes. We're all very tolerant of each other's faith here," Jack said. "And we have a drunken brawl to sort out."

That NCIS special agent couldn't arrive too soon, he thought. If only to distract Kearsy.

*****

Washington Naval Yard, United States of America, Earth, December 25th, 1999

Jack greeted them on the landing pad - which was a bit crowded, Adora noticed, with three shuttles parked next to each other, including the one that brought Catra and her here. "Supreme Commander." He saluted.

"General." She nodded at him.

"Sorry for ruining your holidays."

"Don't worry. We're not celebrating Christmas," Adora told him.

"Not yet," Catra added with a grin. "But we're working on it."

"Oh?" Jack looked surprised.

Adora softly sighed. "Several shops in Bright Moon have Christmas decorations."

Catra nodded. "Earth cultural imperialism is making progress."

Adora frowned. She knew Catra wasn't serious, not really, but some princesses were concerned.

"Soon, the entire galaxy will know the joys of Christmas shopping!" Jack commented as they walked into the building.

“So, where are our missionaries?” Catra asked after she stopped giggling.

“They weren’t actually missionaries,” Jack said. “According to the interviews I saw, the Clones didn’t try to convert anyone.”

That was good to hear. Adora had feared the worst when she had heard about the ‘altercation’.

“I sense a ‘but’ coming.” Catra cocked her head to the side.

Jack sighed. “Yep. While the Clones weren’t trying to convert anyone, neither did they hold back when a drunk sailor asked them what they thought about Christmas. And they didn’t back down when challenged, so…”

Adora winced. “‘Be polite but don’t lie’.”

“Huh?”

“That were their instructions when asked about their… faith,” Adora explained, clenching her teeth a little. “According to Priest.”

“Who wouldn’t lie to his goddess?” Jack looked at her as they waited before the lift.

“He wouldn’t lie,” Adora told him with a firm nod.

“He would interpret orders to suit him and be vague when necessary, like any good subordinate officer showing initiative, but he wouldn’t lie to Adora,” Catra confirmed.

Jack snorted, probably at her view of what made a ‘good subordinate officer’, when the lift arrived. As soon as the doors closed behind them, he said: “Someone’s playing games. They called in NCIS. The Navy Criminal Investigation Service.”

“Yes?” Adora frowned. “Several people were hurt in the brawl, weren’t they? And hurting people is a crime, isn’t it?”

“Yes, but there’s a certain leeway. This kind of incident is usually handled without calling in NCIS,” Jack explained. “I wouldn’t say it’s normal for sailors on leave to brawl, but it’s not exactly rare. And we have a lot of sailors.”

“And who’s playing games, and what do they want?” Catra asked. She looked alert now - tense, even.

Of course, Adora thought, that would remind her of Horde politics.

“Ah, that I don’t know. Not yet.” Jack frowned. “With the brawl happening at a party, news spread quickly.”

Adora nodded. Then the lift stopped, and she straightened and raised her chin a little. This was serious.

“Your Divine Highness! Your most faithful servant is at your command!”

Adora pressed her lips together. Priest didn’t have to bow - they were on duty. Not that he had to bow even if they were off duty, anyway. “Greetings, Priest.” She nodded at him. “Admiral Kearsy.”

The Admiral saluted her with a deep frown and a glance at Priest. Almost a scowl, actually.

Adora wasn’t surprised - Priest could be annoying. Very annoying. She looked at the middle-aged man in a suit next to the Admiral.

“Adora, Cara, that’s Special Agent Banks,” Jack said. “Special Agent - Supreme Commander of the Alliance Princess She-Ra. And Catra.”

“Ma’am.” He nodded at her.

“Special Agent.” She smiled at him. “So, you’ve interrogated the people involved. What happened?” Straight and to the point. Get the intel you needed to make a decision, as she had been taught in cadet training.

“Ah, we’re still at the start of the investigation,” Banks said. “We have wildly differing testimonies that we need to sort out and compare with other pieces of evidence. I cannot yet say with any certainty what exactly happened last evening.”

“We do have records from security cameras, though, that show that my people were attacked and defended themselves, Your Divine Highness,” Priest cut in. “As befitting your faithful, they did not escalate what might have been a mere cultural misunderstanding to violence.”

“So, the sailors threw the first punch, huh?” Catra asked.

“They were provoked!” Admiral Kearsy blurted out. “You cannot fault a man for losing his temper when his religion is insulted on the eve of our most holy celebration!”

Adora winced. So, it was about religion.

“Actually, you can,” Jack cut in. “I do remember orders to that extent. And laws.”

“I find that claim implausible, Admiral,” Priest said in a mild tone. “As Her Divine Highness taught us, other religions are to be respected. Even if their adherents might not respect ours.”

“Your people claimed that the birth of Christ was made up!” Kearsy bellowed.

Adora winced again.

“That is incorrect. My people merely remarked that it was unlikely that Christ was born on this exact date but that it was claimed so by the early Christian Church to coopt another religion’s holiday,” Priest retorted. “Which is generally considered a smart move for spreading the faith, as far as I understand, and, therefore, could be considered a compliment, provided your faith, unlike ours, does not stipulate honesty.”

“Don’t mock my faith!” Kearsy spat. “Your people were also comparing your…” he trailed off and glared at Adora. “...your commander to *Jesus our Lord and Saviour*!”

Adora froze.

Priest didn’t. “Yes?” He cocked his head in apparent - and fake, Adora knew it! - surprise. “Why wouldn’t we?”

“You cannot compare our Lord to… a mere person!” Kearsy bellowed.

“Please do not insult Her Divine Highness,” Priest said. “Her Divine Power and Grace has been proven countless times. In living memory, no less.”

“I’m no goddess!” Adora blurted out.

“And her humility is without equal as well,” Priest said.

Adora closed her eyes so she didn’t have to see Catra’s wide grin.

*****

Holiday Season Part 2

Washington D.C., December 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

The house hadn't changed since Samantha Carter had visited the last time. Which had been quite a while ago, before her father had been healed by Adora, actually. Before they had made up. Sam was happy about that, of course. Her Dad was alive, and the rift between them had been healed. And they could celebrate Christmas together. Which also is a good thing, Sam told herself firmly as she walked up to the door.

Unless there was an emergency, she wouldn't be able to spend Christmas in her lab, anyway. The General would probably check on her. Not that she wanted to spend Christmas in her lab. Not really.

Taking a deep breath, she rang the doorbell.

"I'm coming!"

She blinked. That wasn't her father's voice. That was…

The door was pulled open, and Sam found herself looking at her niece, Lisa. "Aunt Sam!" Before Sam could say anything, the girl turned her head and yelled: "Dad! Gramps! Aunt Sam's here!"

Her brother and his family were here? Sam blinked.

"Come in!" Lisa grabbed her hand and started to tug on it, and Sam followed her inside.

"Aunt Sam! Did you bring us presents?" David, her nephew, asked.

"David!" Mark's wife appeared in the door leading to the kitchen, an apron covering her front. "What did I tell you about being good?" Then she smiled. "Hello, Sam. Merry Christmas!"

“Hello, Marian.” Sam nodded at her. “I didn’t know you were visiting Dad.”

“Oh! You don’t have presents, then!”

“David!”

“We’ll take money, too,” Lisa said, smiling impishly. “You have money, right? Dad said you live for your work, so you can’t be spending much, right?”

Sam raised her eyebrows. “He did?”

“Hello, Sam!”

And there was her brother, standing in the hallway leading to the backyard. Behind him, just closing the door, was Dad. Both were wearing winter jackets.

“Sam!” Dan beamed at her. “You made it.”

“It’s a Christmas miracle,” Mark commented.

Sam frowned, and he grimaced. “Sorry.”

“‘Christmas miracle’?” David asked in the sudden silence.

“Nothing,” Mark told him. “Just a stupid joke.”

“Yes. Very stupid,” Marian told him.

“Anyway,” Dad said. “Come, join us in the living room!”

Sam was tempted to comment on the fact that Marian was going back into the kitchen, but like her and Dad’s military career, that was a touchy subject.

“So, do you have money?” Lisa apparently had clear priorities.

“I already sent your parents the money for your gifts,” Sam told her. “I didn’t know you would be travelling to Washington.”

“It was a rather spontaneous decision,” Mark said as he sat down on the old and worn couch in the living room. Next to it, a Christmas tree with familiar decorations stood. It was a bit too tall for the room’s ceiling, and the tip was bent to the side, the star meant to be mounted on its top dangling from it instead.

Sam joined him on the couch while her nephew and niece sat down on the carpet, grabbing the toys spread out there.

“I told Mark that both of us would be in Washington for the holidays,” Dad added as he sank into his favourite seat. “Barring an emergency.”

Mark snorted. “And it might have been the last opportunity to catch a flight on an aeroplane. I didn’t want David and Lisa to miss out on that experience.”

David nodded. “We watched ‘Star Princess and the Snake Empire’ on the flight! We wouldn’t have had the time to do that on a shuttle!”

Sam nodded, suppressing the urge to correct her brother about the odds that commercial travel would switch to shuttles in the next few years.

“Have you seen the movie?” Lisa asked. “Dad said you live it!”

Sam narrowed her eyes at her brother, who grinned in response, before smiling at her niece. “No, I haven’t seen the movie. I rarely have the time to watch movies.”

“Ah!” Lisa nodded and smiled at her, sitting cross-legged in front of Sam. “So, the movie starts with the Star Princess and her friends on their planet, Eternia. They’re having fun with all the animals, but then the Snake People attack, and the whole forest - they have a magical forest where the trees have chocolate fruits - is set on fire! But Star Princess’s friend Aqua can control water, and so she…”

Sam felt her smile freeze a little bit as she realised that her niece apparently was going to tell her the entire movie's plot - a plot that sounded very much like it was 'inspired' by the Horde War, with the Horde replaced by obvious Goa'uld expies.

Someone at Disney must have commissioned that movie as revenge for the Etherians' refusal to respect their copyright, Sam thought. She could only hope the General didn't hear about this - he'd use it for a mandatory movie night.

Why did she decide that she couldn't spend the day in her lab, anyway? Because she hadn't seen her family in months, she reminded herself.

"...and then Star Princess rode her pegasus to the Horde sky fortress, and…"

"It's actually an alicorn," Sam said before she could help herself. "Sorry," she quickly added.

Mark snickered. "You'd know the difference - you met the real thing, right?"

Both Lisa and Davis gaped at her.

"That's classified," Sam said, frowning at her dad. He was the only one in the family who was aware that she was a close friend of the Etherians. Of course, her friendship wasn't that much of a secret, considering how many knew about it…

"Classified?" Lisa asked.

"That means Aunt Sam goes to prison if she tells us," David told her.

"I didn't spill," Dad claimed.

"I figured it out from how often you were in the news," Mark said with a satisfied smirk.

Her brother wasn't stupid, Sam reminded herself. She sighed. "It's classified. We're at war."

"Oh! Are you going to ride alicorns into battle?" Lisa asked.

"Or dinosaurs?" David added.

"No," Sam said. "That's just the show, not reality." Riding Swift Wind into battle? She wasn't Adora. And she doubted Adora would ride him into battle, either.

"Aw." Lisa pouted. "And will you attack the Horde Sky Fortress?"

"The Etherians already defeated the Horde, duh," David said. "Now they are fighting snakes!"

"The Alliance is engaged in a war with the Goa'uld Empire," she corrected him. A war that the Goa'uld were not yet aware of, actually.

"Yes, the snakes!" David nodded.

"A war that keeps your aunt very busy," Mark added. Sam could hear the 'too busy to visit her family' clearly even though he didn't say it out loud.

And so could Dad. He frowned. "Sam's essential for the Alliance."

Sam, not her work, Sam noted.

Fortunately, Mark didn't pick up that nuance. He slowly nodded. "But at least you managed to visit over the holidays." He tilted his head and frowned slightly. "You're staying over the holidays, aren't you?"

"I'll visit in my free time," Sam told him. "But I don't have leave over the holidays." And she didn't want leave anyway. She had too many projects to tend to, and her friends needed her.

“You have to work on Christmas?” Lisa stared at Sam as if she had heard that Christmas was getting cancelled.

“We’re at war,” Sam said.

“And you’re doing your duty,” Mark said.

Sam ignored the familiar hint of bitterness in his voice. She wouldn’t start that old argument again.

Fortunately, neither did Dad. “Well, at least you can travel around the world faster than you can drive through Washington these days.”

“What?” Mark looked surprised, even though he had commented about shuttles rendering planes obsolete before.

“Shuttles are far faster than planes,” Dad said.

“I didn’t know they were that fast…”

“I don’t have a personal shuttle,” Sam pointed out.

“General O’Neill does, though.” Of course, Dad would have heard those rumours!

“Which he uses,” Sam said. She didn’t bother denying the rumours. That would only make her brother tease her. Or make assumptions that were completely inappropriate and wrong.

“Who’s General O’Neill?” Lisa asked.

“My former commanding officer,” Sam told her.

“And you can use his shuttle?” Lisa looked impressed.

“If I need it, I can require a shuttle for transport,” Sam said. She needed one every time she visited the Spacelab in person or had to move between different bases.

“To visit us?” Lisa asked.

“That wouldn’t be a need,” Sam corrected her. “But if my duties lead me to Washington, I will visit. You’re staying the whole holiday?” she asked Mark.

“Yes. Marian’s family was not amused, but since we stayed with them every year…” He shrugged. “They can’t complain.”

Neither Dad nor Sam commented on the reasons why Mark and his family had visited Marian’s parents every holiday and not them.

Sam tried to change the topic again. “I might need to get a copy of that movie,” she said. And watch it so she would know if it could cause problems with the Etherians.

“Can we have it when you’re done?” Lisa looked hopefully at her.

David nodded with the same expression.

“Well… it’s a bit too late to get a copy today,” Mark said with a glance at the clock on the wall. “But we can get one tomorrow. And watch it together. Consider it a late Christmas present, Sam.”

“Yes!” Lisa cheered.

“Yay!” David nodded so rapidly, Sam was briefly worried for his health.

She thought about bowing out - she had only planned to visit today for the big dinner - but faced with her niece and nephew’s beaming faces, she couldn’t disappoint them.

It really is a potential problem for our relations with Etheria, she told herself to soothe her guilty conscience.

It didn’t quite work.

*****

Pentagon, Washington D.C., December 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"So, has the special agent finished their investigation yet?" Catra asked as she leaned back in her seat and put her feet on the table.

"Catra!" Adora hissed next to her.

Catra rolled her eyes. "It's not as if this is a serious matter," she said, loud enough to be overheard by the others in the meeting room. "Someone just wanted to feel important."

"This is a serious matter!" Kearsy bellowed, as expected.

Catra snorted. Really, didn't the man realise that he had been set up? A bunch of soldiers brawling was a matter for their officers to settle. It wasn't as if anyone had died - they hadn't even been hurt seriously. Not enough for needing Adora's healing magic, at least - which disproved Catra's earlier (and far-fetched) suspicion that someone suffering from a disease or whatever had arranged that to get Adora involved, hoping she would heal them. In any case, Kearsy shouldn't have become involved in the first place or, at least, should have dropped the matter when the Navy police had taken over. He should have followed Jack's example, who had dropped the thing on Adora as soon as he had an excuse and must be enjoying the holidays right now.

"I fail to see why this investigation should persist," Priest cut in. "The records we saw were clear - your sailors attacked my people first. And since I, following the example Her Divine Highness set, agreed not to pursue punishment of the attackers, the matter should be settled already."

Adora nodded. "Yes. There's no need to punish anyone if their victims forgave them."

Catra doubted that any of the hurt Clones would have dared refuse to forgive their enemies when Adora asked them, but that wasn't her problem.

“We still don’t know the exact circumstances of the brawl, so any assumptions about guilt seem premature,” the base commander, Admiral Jeffries, apparently called back from a vacation with his family, said, glancing back and forth between Kearsy and Adora. The guy didn’t want to be here any more than Catra did.

“As my people told me, they merely answered honestly when asked about their opinion of this holiday,” Priest said. “All in accordance with Her Divine Highness’ orders,” he added with a deep nod toward Adora. “That this was taken as an insult by your sailors was not their fault. But even if it were, that would not excuse an assault on them.”

“You cannot expect a man to suffer such an insult without reacting!” Kearsy snapped.

Priest tilted his head slightly in apparent - and, Catra was sure, fake confusion. “I was under the impression that this was a core tenet of your religion. To turn the other cheek instead of defending yourself, much less counter-attacking, even when you are physically assaulted.”

Kearsy ground his teeth. “That’s not what it means!” he spat. “And they attacked their faith, not the sailors themselves!”

“I bow to your expertise,” Priest replied in a mild tone that left Kearsy even more furious. “My own faith does not require us to react with violence when questioned - quite the opposite, actually.”

Admiral Jeffries cleared his throat. “I think that a thorough investigation would help us to decide what punishment is appropriate for the attack on your soldiers.”

“And you are free to do so,” Catra said. “But that doesn’t mean we have to stay involved with this. We’ve got better things to do.” Hell, even watching paint dry would be better than this - at least she’d be able to take a nap without Adora feeling embarrassed.

“We trust that your judgement in this matter will be fair,” Priest added with more fake sincerity that once again riled Kearsy up.

“Do you expect us to sacrifice good sailors for politics?”

Catra couldn’t resist. “Isn’t that a tradition for your country?”

“Catra!”

“What? I’ve read their history,” Catra said, shrugging. “They sent their Navy to open other countries for their trade.”

“Are you insulting the US Navy?” Kearsy glared at her.

Admiral Jeffries cleared his throat again. “I think we should focus on the matter at hand. Which is, if I understand your stance correctly, a disciplinary matter left to the involved sailors’ commander.”

“Yes,” Adora said, nodding emphatically.

“As Her Divine Highness mandates,” Priest added.

Kearsy managed to nod without blowing up.

“Great. The matter’s settled then,” Catra said, taking her feet off the table and standing up to stretch. “Let’s go back home.”

But as they filed out of the room, an aide approached Admrial Jeffries. Catra’s ears twitched as she listened to their whispered conversation.

“Sir, there’s been a complication.”

“What?”

“The press is covering the incident.”

“What?”

Catra muttered a curse under her breath. "Someone must have leaked this to the press." This would greatly increase the pressure on anyone involved.

Then again, that was probably their goal, she added to herself with a glance at Kearsy.

"What are they saying?" Adora asked.

The aide winced. "Uh…"

"Spit it out!" Kearsy growled.

"Most call it 'the Christmas Brawl'," the man replied. "But some of the more conservative media are calling it an 'attack on Christmas'."

Catra could imagine what those news agencies said about this and clenched her teeth. She was really, really sick of that part of Earth's media. "So much for this being settled," she said.

They had to discuss this with Jack and the others.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, December 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and while the Pentagon refuses to comment on the issue and the Alliance spokesperson has claimed that an investigation is still underway, sources usually in the know claim that the Supreme Commander of the Alliance herself, She-Ra, Princess of Power, was called to heal the personnel involved. That means this wasn't merely a brawl amongst drunken soldiers, something anyone living near a base is probably familiar with, but a serious fight. James, what do you think the consequences of this will be?"

"Well, Bob, such a bloody, if you'll pardon the pun, altercation means that there's serious tension between the different factions of the Alliance."

"Which factions do you mean? We've heard allegations that many Earth soldiers resent the Etherians for their favourite treatment. Some claim that Earth soldiers are used as cannon fodder on the ground while the Etherians stay safe in orbit."

"Ah, I cannot comment on the validity of such claims, but given the technological and population difference between Earth and Etheria, it's only natural that we - Earth - would mainly fight ground battles. Don't forget that Etheria in total has less than a fifth of the population of the United States."

"But that's math. For the soldier on the ground, sitting in the trenches while others stay safely aboard spaceships, that won't mean much, will it?"

"Indeed, Bob, while that perspective is limited, and possibly misleading, it's still a valid point to be taken into account."

"And there's more. While it would be reaching to claim, as some of our less integer colleagues do, that Etheria is waging a 'War on Christmas', it is commonly known that the Etherians are rather aggressively spreading their religion on Earth and in space. I could imagine that such proselytising would not be received well by devout Christians."

"Once more, I have to agree. There's a saying that there are no atheists in foxholes, as you might know."

"I didn't, James, but it's kind of fitting, isn't it?"

"Yes. Anyway, we've heard complaints about Etheria's religion spreading on Earth for months now. While most of its followers are, unsurprisingly, located in India, the Church of She-Ra is also growing in the West, and that causes tension. This incident might just be the tip of the iceberg, so to speak, an indication of a lingering and growing rift inside the Alliance."

"That sounds daunting, James."

"That's because it is daunting, Bob."

Jack O'Neill switched the TV off and turned to look at the others in the room. "Sounds like a bunch of hot air to me," he said. "Just people stirring up emotion for ratings."

Catra nodded, but Adora was shaking her head. "Admiral Kearsy seemed to share this view."

"Kearsy is an idiot," Jack said. "And he'll probably be removed from his post over this." Someone had to take the fall for this, and Kearsy was the most exposed - and the most expendable - amongst the higher ranks involved here. Although the yard commander might be sacrificed instead, if Kearsy managed to shore up enough support. Unless Adora personally intervened, which she wouldn't do. Probably not.

"Do you think someone set him up?" Catra asked.

Jack shrugged. "Someone used the opportunity to let him step into this, at least." Staff politics, how he loathed them!

"So, someone's risking the Alliance to get rid of a rival?" Catra asked.

"Or someone's trying to prevent Kearsy from risking the Alliance for his beliefs," Jack said. "You met the man - he sounded like he was all-in for the whole 'fire and brimstone' stuff." Hell, Kearsy had made Priest look like a moderate or sceptic.

"'Fire and brimstone'?" Adora asked.

Daniel pushed his glasses up. "It's referring to the threat of hell and damnation in Christian dogma. Jack is, I believe, using it to refer to more extremist churches and views."

"Yes." Jack nodded. "People who talk about your immortal soul being in peril whenever you do something they don't like."

"Idiots and bigots, you mean," Catra said.

"Well… mainstream Christianity focuses on love and compassion, both divine and, ah, mortal," Daniel said. "But there are extremists in every religion."

"Like Priest." Adora sighed.

"He's actually quite… restrained for the leader of an expanding religion," Daniel said. "Or maybe diplomatic would be more precise."

"Smooth," Jack said. Priest knew how to play others and exploit the rules and regulations. Jack couldn't even tell if the Clone was sincere in his belief or merely used the adoration people held for She-ra for his own goals. Though even if he were, there were worse messages to spread than 'be more like She-Ra'. Far worse ones.

"So, what do we do about this?" Adora asked, pointing at the TV.

"Nothing," Jack said.

"Nothing?" She frowned at him.

"Ah, you think this will blow over?" Daniel asked him.

Jack nodded. "It's a bunch of hot air," he repeated himself. "There's no such 'rift'. Soldiers complain all the time, and everyone thinks the other branches have an easy job. You know, like they call us the Chair Force?"

Catra snickered.

"Anyway, I like to think I know my soldiers, and they don't have a problem with each other like those idiots claim," Jack went on. And, of course, anyone who actually fought on the ground knows you were in the thick of it." That meant a lot more than what some idiots said on TV or preached in church.

He didn't miss how both Adora and Catra looked at Daniel.

"Yes, I would concur. While there are bound to be some religious tensions, that's nothing unusual for such a large force as the Alliance. And, so far at least, the media attention focused on this seems limited to the United States—none of the European news agencies is paying a lot of attention to the entire affair. So, I think this is an isolated incident and not indicative of a larger problem."

Adora seemed relieved. The girl really needed to stop feeling responsible for everything, in Jack's opinion. It wasn't as if she were an actual goddess.

"So, you see, there's no need to worry about your faithful," Catra said with a grin.

Adora frowned at her in return.

"Indeed," Teal'c spoke up. "On the contrary, your church has great potential for turning the false gods' followers into our allies. Its ideals may appeal to many amongst the Jaffa who would scorn your other religions. If you have the time, a visit to the Jaffa currently held by the Alliance could prove helpful."

Adora blinked.

Jack looked at his friend. "Is there something you'd like to tell us, Teal'c?"

"I have been working with the captured followers of the false gods, as have members of your church," Teal'c replied. "We have made inroads with many of them, especially after you released the synthetic symbionts. That you visited daily before that to ensure those who had lost their symbionts didn't die also left a favourable impression on many."

That was good news, Jack decided. Even if the image of a bunch - or an army - of Jaffa fanatically devoted to Adora was a bit concerning as well. "Merry Christmas?" he said with a wry grin.

Adora didn't grin in return.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 25th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"...and that's why we aren't going to visit the prison camp this week."

Adora frowned at the grinning Catra. It wasn't funny at all! She looked at her friends for support. Bow winced and avoided meeting her eyes. Either he was embarrassed or felt guilty, which wasn't good. And Glimmer…

…stared directly at her with a serious, determined expression. "You should visit them. They're your people."

"What?" Adora blurted out. "They aren't! I am no goddess!"

"But they follow you and look to you for guidance," Glimmer, standing behind the desk in her office, told her. "And you have visited the prisoners before."

"When I had to heal the wounded and Haken," Adora retorted.

"And they worshipped you back then already," Bow pointed out. "Teal'c didn't tell you anything new."

"Yes, but…" Adora trailed off. What could she say? That she had hoped they would stop worshipping her if she stopped visiting? That if she hadn't wanted to deal with them? "I didn't think it would spread."

"But it did." Glimmer shook her head. "And you can't ignore that."

"You don't owe them anything," Catra said, sitting on the edge of Glimmer's desk. She put down one of the crystals serving as paperweights that she had been playing with. "If they decide to worship you, that's on them. It doesn't make you responsible for them!" She turned to glare at Glimmer. "That's not how it works."

“I wouldn’t turn people away who wanted to become my subjects,” Glimmer told her. She frowned for a moment and added: “Not unless they were dishonest or tried to use me or something, of course. But people honestly wanting to join Bright Moon?” She shook her head.

“I’m not a ruling princess,” Adora said. “I don’t have a kingdom.”

Catra nodded.

“You don’t have a kingdom, but you have people who follow you,” Glimmer retorted.

“That’s not your fault or responsibility,” Catra said. She didn’t look amused any more.

Adora bit her lower lip. “I’m no goddess. But they won’t believe me.”

“And that’s their fault,” Catra said.

“It doesn’t matter whose fault it is,” Glimmer said. “The fact is that people follow you. If you don’t lead them, others will - and in your name.”

Priest. Adora clenched her teeth. The Clone was… infuriating was the word. He claimed to worship her, to obey her every word, as he put it, and yet he wouldn’t listen at all when she said she wasn’t a goddess!

“You could disavow them,” Catra said.

She could. She might not be able to convince everyone that she wasn’t a goddess, but she could convince people that Priest or anyone else claiming so didn’t speak for her.

“You should only do that if they betray you,” Glimmer objected. “Not if they’re just annoying.”

Adora looked at her friend. “I don’t want to be worshipped.”

"There's a lot of stuff I don't want to do or deal with," Glimmer said. "But I do it because someone has to, and I am the Queen of Bright Moon, so it falls to me."

"You aren't the queen of Bright Moon," Catra pointed out to Adora.

Bow cleared his throat. "But is it that different from being the Supreme Commander of the Alliance?" He held up a hand before Adora could tell him that people didn't worship a commander as a goddess. "You do give orders and lead people, and do your best to fix things if they need fixing and that people do the right thing. Whether they call you commander or goddess doesn't really change that, does it?"

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again. That… wasn't wrong.

"And Priest and his people would answer to you anyway as the leader of the Alliance," Glimmer added.

Adora pressed her lips together. Would Priest actually be in the Alliance if he didn't worship her? Sure, WrongHordak and his people didn't worship her and had joined the Alliance, but that didn't mean every other Clone would act the same. Like Hordak, who led First Fleet's remains, WrongHordak had his own reasons for joining the Alliance. Reasons Priest and others might not share.

On the other hand, letting people worship her as a goddess so they would help you fight the Goa'uld felt wrong. It was like exploiting their faith - like something the Go'auld did! "I don't want them to follow me because they think I am a goddess!" she blurted out.

"But they do think you're a goddess," Glimmer retorted. "That's not your fault - you never claimed to be a goddess. But it's a fact we can't just ignore. Not without serious repercussions."

Bow nodded. "I've looked into Earth's religions. All of the major ones have had problems with their followers becoming radicalised.

And the most radicalised are often those who converted from another religion."

Oh. "Like those who start worshipping me?" Adora asked.

Bow nodded with a grimace.

Catra hissed a curse.

And Glimmer nodded.

Adora sighed. She didn't want this, none of this, but she couldn't ignore it. If she left her… followers to their own devices, who knew what they would end up doing? And in her name? Unwanted or not, it was her responsibility. She couldn't, wouldn't run from that. "I won't act as a goddess," she said. "I won't lie to them. But I will visit them." And keep a close eye on Priest. A closer eye.

Catra sighed as Glimmer and Bow nodded with sympathetic smiles.

The sudden silence was broken by the guards announcing that Entrapta had arrived.

A moment later, Entrapta entered the office with a wide smile.

"Hey!" Entrapta beamed at them, holding up a disc. "Sam just told me that Earth made a movie with us!"

What?

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 26th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"No! I can't end like this! I was so clo…AARGHHHHH!"

"Let that be a lesson to you! Love, not might, conquers all!"

"Yes, meow love!"

Samantha Carter winced while the ending credits scrolled over the holoprojected screen, and everyone else in the room turned to look or glare at her. In hindsight, she should have called Daniel and told him about this movie so he could handle breaking this to her friends instead of sending a copy to Entrapta.

But after a whole day at her family, being badgered by her niece and nephew with questions about 'the real star princess', demands to meet 'the real alicorn' and wide-eyed pleas for stories about space and trying to ignore her brother's passive-aggressive sniping at her career and the duties that entailed and her sister-in-law's questions, encouraged by her traitorous dad, about her love life, she hadn't really been thinking clearly.

And now she was facing a bunch of magical princesses and former alien warlords who didn't seem to be enamoured by their portrayal in the movie.

"I do not have horns or a tail. And *I* threw Horde Prime into a shaft - I didn't fall into a shaft by tripping over a cat-shapeshifter!"

"I *am* a cat - I don't change into a cat! And I would have *kicked* you down a shaft."

"I don't sound like that at all! And I cannot fly, whether it's the full moon or not!"

"I don't have a curse that makes me burn if I cover up my chest - I just like having my midriff free!"

"I didn't conquer Etheria! Much less the galaxy! And I don't want to!"

The only one who didn't seem to be annoyed by the movie was Entrapta, Sam noted. A silver lining, at least.

"Being a bot would be so cool! I think I could adapt metal tentacles like that!"

Or not. Sam winced. "I don't think you should replace your body with a bot body," she said. "And I think your hair already does everything the tentacles in the movie did."

"Oh, right." Entrapta pouted. "Forgot about that. But I could build a bot that looks just like the movie-me!"

"Ah… that might violate copyright," Sam said.

"Copyright?" Glimmer snarled. "What about *our* copyright? Whoever made this movie…"

"Disney did," Catra cut in.

Disney distributed it, but it had been made by a new and nominally independent production firm, Sam knew. Probably in an attempt to shield the corporation from any backlash. Or to reduce taxes somehow. But this wasn't the time to bring that up.

"...Disney used us for their movie!" Glimmer went on. "Why didn't we hear about his before… this?" She gestured at the screen, which was fading to black. "Someone should have told us about people making a movie like that about us."

Sam winced again. "It's not the first such movie or series. It's just the most successful." Thanks to her niece and nephew's enthusiasm, she now knew far more about cartoons than she had ever wanted to know. "And probably the one that is the most obvious about its, ah, 'inspiration'."

"Really?" Adora frowned.

"And no one stopped them?" Glimmer glared at Sam as if that was her fault. "And what did Julie and Mr Brown do? They're supposed to help with our image!"

Sam was a scientist, not a PR specialist. And the relations between the Etherians and their PR consultants were none of her business. But she spoke up anyway: "The movies and series are

quite popular amongst children." At least amongst the children in her family. "They probably didn't think that this would hurt you."

"It hurts my image," Hordak complained. "I was a competent warlord, not such a clumsy oaf! And it claims I was Horde Prime!"

"And it claims I defected over a can of tuna," Catra added.

"Well… you love fish?" Adora smiled weakly.

"Not the point."

"It takes a lot of liberties with what actually happened," Bow said. "I know it's not meant to be a documentary, but they could have stuck a bit closer to the real story."

Glimmer turned to frown at him. "They should have changed more things! They made me out to be a figurehead! All I do is fly in the moonlight and hold speeches! And I get shot down in every battle so Adora can rescue me!"

Catra shrugged. "Someone paid a lot of attention to our history," she said with a grin. "They even have the cat defect and sneak into the prison to save you."

"Could we have a leak?" Adora asked.

"None of the, ah, information in the movie was classified," Sam said. She had checked.

"It's still a lot of detail," Adora retorted. "Someone must have collected a lot of information for this."

"Disney is a big corporation. And they might have wanted to make a point," Sam suggested.

"Do they really expect that we agree to protect their copyright claims on Etheria if they stop this movie?" Glimmer scoffed. "So, what do we do about this?"

"Can we do something about this?" Bow asked.

Sam wasn't a lawyer, but she doubted that. As persons of public interest, her friends were, as someone had called it, 'fair game' for the media.

"Why would we want to do something about it?" Entrapta asked. "It's a fun cartoon!"

If Sam liked such cartoons. And hadn't been forced to watch it with two enthusiastic kids commenting on every scene.

"But it makes it look as if I - as 'Star Princess' - saved Etheria by myself," Adora said. "That's wrong."

"Well, Priest will love the movie," Catra commented. Then she blinked. "Wait a minute…"

"...do you think he had something to do about this?" Glimmer sounded sceptical.

Sam doubted that herself. If Disney were working with aliens, that should have been noticed by someone. People were supposed to keep an eye on such 'business ties'.

"Oh, his book." Catra sighed. "The writers must have read his collection of She-Ra's heroic deeds."

Adora groaned. "Does that mean the movie's protected by religious freedom? I mean, I don't think we should try to ban it anyway, that would be wrong, right?"

Glimmer's expression made it clear that she disagreed, but the others nodded, to Sam's relief.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, December 27th, 1999 (Earth Time)

"We were aware of the movies inspired by you, yes."

Mr Brown smiled as if there was nothing wrong with that, Catra found. And unlike Julie, who was wincing a little, he was unfazed by the frowns from the princesses present.

"And you didn't tell us?" Glimmer asked.

"We thought you knew about them," he replied. "Etheria seems to be importing all mainstream media from Earth - at least based on the complaints about copyright violations we passed on to you."

They hadn't seen those shows and movies, though. At least Catra and her friends hadn't. She really needed to check the black market herself to see if there were other things they were missing. Stuff that many might not dare to mention to them, but others might want to use against them.

"Why would you get complaints? We have diplomatic channels for that," Adora asked, interrupting Catra's plans.

"And we get complaints there," Glimmer added. "They don't seem to understand that we don't have any copyright on Etheria."

"Oh, they understand that," Julie said. "But they don't accept it. It's why we have been 'finalising the last details' about the cultural exchange program for so long. Pressure from the labels and studios on the actors and performers."

"Oh."

Well, that made sense. "Sounds like Horde politics," Catra commented.

"What?" Hordak seemed surprised.

Catra sighed under her breath. "If the Force Captain in charge of supplies wanted a favour from you, you helped them out if you wanted to get your supplies on time."

“That’s… corruption!” Hordak shook his head. “Sabotage and treason, even!”

Catra shrugged. “That’s how things worked for those who weren’t in command of the Horde.” Like she had been, or Shadow Weaver. And Hordak, of course.

“Are you sure? I don’t think I ever had to deal with stuff like that,” Scorpia said with a frown. “And I was a Force Captain for years. They never said anything about that in Force Captain Orientation, either.”

Catra snorted. “That’s because you always did whatever favour people asked for.”

“Well, we were all on the same side, so why wouldn’t I help the other Force Captains out if I could?”

Glimmer cleared her throat. “Can we talk about the corruption problem in the Horde later? We have a problem at hand.”

“Do you mean the copyright complaints or the movies?” Mr Brown asked. “Because the movies and assorted media aren’t a problem for your reputation. All the movies and series that we watched display you in a very positive light - and we watched a lot of them with the kids. We would have to spend a lot of money to get that kind of coverage.”

“‘Positive light’?” Glimmer spat. “I look useless and clumsy!”

“I sound like a fool,” Hordak joined in.

“They wrecked my outfit. Have you seen the action figures? That bow would never work!”

“They make me look like a goddess!”

Those were all perfectly on the nose, in Catra’s opinion. The speech impediment she had in half the series was a bother, but at least all cast her as a cat. And teasing Adora about the cartoon

series where she was a tiger Adora rode to battle hadn't gotten old yet.

"They styled a bot and an octopus after me!" Entrapta, of course, was happy with the media featuring her.

"I think I'm far too scary in the shows," Scorpia said. "My stinger doesn't have deadly poison!"

"I remember you throwing tanks at us," Adora told her.

"Well, yes?" Scorpia tilted her head. "I didn't hit anyone, did I?"

Catra rolled her eyes. "Anyway, I gather the copyright violations are the real problem?"

"Yes." Julie nodded. "And they are the reason that even if we wanted to stop such 'inspired media', we wouldn't succeed. Even if the shows hadn't changed the characters modelled after you significantly, at least where their visuals are concerned."

"There's also the fact that as persons of public interest, you wouldn't have good chances to win a court case even if the media used your likeness and names - at least with the Saturday morning cartoons we saw," Mr Brown added. "Adult entertainment would be different, of course."

Catra clenched her teeth and hissed. She hadn't thought about that. That changed things. If anyone tried to…

"'Adult entertainment'?" Scorpia looked confused.

"That's media aimed at adults, usually with sexual content!" Entrapta cheerfully explained before anyone else could say anything. "Also known as porn."

Scorpia blinked. "Oh. Like the dirty pictures soldiers hide in their barracks?"

"Yes. And movies. And I guess some live performances qualify as well."

"Is there porn with us?" Glimmer looked shocked.

As did Adora and most of the others, Catra noted.

"We haven't seen any such, ah, productions related to your likenesses," Mr Brown quickly said. "If we would encounter any, we would take measures to stop it." He smiled weakly. "And while there are strong precedents against censorship, at least in the United States, we're all too aware that the crews of the fleet protecting Earth hold you in high regard and might not react well to any such media."

Right. The Clones would not like porn featuring Adora. Not at all. And they wouldn't really care about any anti-censorship laws at all. At least Priest was unlikely to react violently, but Catra had a feeling that that might not help whoever might be responsible for such media much.

That Clone was a bit too sneaky for her taste.

*****

Holiday Season Part 3

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, December 28th, 1999

Jack O'Neill stared at his friends. He couldn't have heard correctly, could he? "Cartoons nearly caused a diplomatic issue?"

"Those are cartoons 'inspired' by the Etherians," Carter explained. "The Etherians have recently become aware of them."

"Ah." That made sense. Sort of. "And they don't like them?"

"Most of them disagree with how they - well, the characters inspired by them - are portrayed," Daniel said. "Even though the portrayal is very positive, especially considering that the cartoons are meant for children."

"Entrapta likes them. Though she might consider them as inspirations for new projects," Carter added.

Jack winced. He wasn't an expert on cartoons - except for The Simpsons - but he had seen enough Saturday morning cartoons as a kid to know that could be a problem. But the others? "You said 'nearly caused a diplomatic issue'. So, they calmed down?"

"Yes, sir." Carter nodded. "Although there are concerns about porn using their likeness."

Daniel nodded as well. "There already is, ah, *erotic fanart* found on the internet, although it has been more or less limited to a subculture. And unlike porn with actors, it's rather hard to find the creators of such pictures."

"We could probably track down individuals if we tried, but it's not worth the effort."

Carter's pride must have been stung by Daniel's comment, Jack noted.

“And it would break several laws,” Daniel added with a frown. “Though I assume that the potential problems with Third Fleet such, ah, oeuvres could cause would have to be taken into account.”

Jack winced. “Right. The religious fanatics crewing spaceships with big honking guns orbiting Earth might take offence to porn depicting their goddess.” God knew that religious fanatics had killed people for less on Earth.

“They haven’t actually complained about the, ah, erotic art,” Daniel pointed out. “So, they might not care about porn either. But if they think Adora hates it…”

Jack frowned. “Why hasn’t there been such porn, anyway? Don’t they love making porn parodies or something?” Noticing the looks he got from everyone - even Teal’c and Sha’re - he quickly added: “I am commanding a multi-national unit of special forces. What do you think I find when I inspect their quarters?”

Teal’c, Daniel and Sha’re nodded, but Carter was still frowning. Well, it was the truth!

“Anyway,” Jack went on, “I would have expected some of that stuff to appear by now.”

Carter switched from frowning at him to staring at her laptop. Which probably had more computing power than the SGC main computer by now if the glimpse of glowing crystal stuff Jack had caught once when she had opened the frame was any indication. “Carter?”

“One second, sir… It seems that there was a recent crackdown on porn studios in Los Angeles. Several porn studios and independent producers are under investigation for various crimes. A number of them were known for producing ‘porn parodies’.” She grimaced at the words, Jack saw. “I would have to verify the information, though - this was only a casual search. And I haven’t investigated foreign countries.”

He snorted. “Someone probably tipped off the cops.” And Jack would bet a week’s worth of jello that this was the NID at work.

“Do you want me to investigate this further?” Carter asked.

Ordering her to investigate porn studios? Jack shook his head. If that ever got out, his fellow generals would try their damnest to get him relieved for that. “No. It’s not a problem, is it?”

“Not currently, sir,” she replied.

“Though it could become a problem,” Daniel objected.

“Didn’t Adora impress on Priest that there wouldn’t be any orbital bombardments without her explicit permission?” Jack asked. “Do you think he’d disobey her?” The Clone was too smart to try anything like that, at least.

“I wasn’t worried about the Clones, Jack. But the Church of She-Ra is growing on Earth. And also in regions where religious riots have broken out in the past,” Daniel said.

“Then Adora should address that,” Jack said. “Unlike other gods, she can tell her followers that violence isn’t the answer in this case.”

“It’s not a joking matter, Jack!” Daniel blurted out.

“Who said I’m joking?” Jack tilted his head at his friend. “People worship her as a goddess. So, why not use that when needed?” They were at war, after all. And it wasn’t as if She-ra would make a worse goddess than any other god or goddess. Quite the contrary, actually.

“It feels a bit manipulative,” Daniel said.

“That’s religion for you, Daniel.” Jack shrugged. “Now, is there anything else we need to discuss before we talk about our holiday plans?”

Daniel blinked. “What do you mean?”

“I believe this is a reference to the holiday events we are planning to attend,” Teal’c said.

“Yep.” Jack grinned. If he had to mingle with generals and politicians, then he needed some help from his friends to endure that. You couldn't always count on an emergency to get you out of such parties, after all.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, December 31st, 1999

Adora wasn’t exactly an expert on parties, but she had attended her share over the years, both on Etheria and on Earth, and the Alliance New Year’s Eve Party wasn’t a fun event. Sure, lots of generals and politicians attended, and a lot of her friends from the Princess Alliance and the Alliance, but… It felt more like the Princess Prom when Catra and Scorpia had shown up than a real party. More like work. Duty.

“You’re worrying again. Stop that.”

Adora turned to frown at Catra. “I’m not…” she pulled her head back when Catra pushed a pastry to her face.

“Try that! It’s an éclair - you’ll love it!” Catra grinned at her.

“You said that about Vegemite.” But Adora still took the pastry - carefully, though she got cream on her fingers anyway - and then carefully bit in it. “Oh!”

“See? It’s great! And so’s Vegemite - you just have no taste!” Catra scarfed down another éclair.

“How can you say that I have no taste?” Adora pouted before she grinned. “I do love you, don’t I?”

Catra blinked, apparently surprised for a moment, then grinned. "Well, I'll chalk that up to dumb luck."

Adora snorted and finished off her own pastry.

"But seriously, just enjoy the food and tell the idiots off if they bother you."

Adora drew a sharp breath. "I can't! I'm the Supreme Commander, and those are our closest allies! We work with them!"

"All the more reason to tell them off if they annoy you - they have to work with you, not the other way around. Besides, as a goddess, you outrank them."

"I am not a goddess!" Adora hissed.

"Well, Priest disagrees." Catra shrugged. "Anyway, just enjoy the party for another…" She checked the clock on the wall. "... twenty-eight minutes. Then we're off to Stargate Command for the *real* New Year's Eve Party!" She grabbed another pastry, something fluffier, and swallowed it whole. "Mhhh. Until then, we can enjoy the food here. Get our money's worth."

Right. The Alliance budget was paying for this party. Adora nodded. "So we should…" She trailed off when the Secretary General of NATO approached her, glass in hand. "Have you tried the wine yet?"

"Ah…" Adora smiled a little weakly. "I…"

"Adora's more of a champagne girl," Catra said. "You know, blonde and bubbly."

"I'm not!"

But the Secretary General laughed. Was he a bit tipsy? Probably. He was usually such a serious man. Although with almost all of NATO in the Alliance, his position was… Adora wouldn't call it redundant, but it was not as important as it had been in the past.

And as Catra had said, it hadn't been all that important in the past either, what with the US calling the shots.

"Well, the food's great," Catra said. "Better than Princess Prom."

"Ah, I've heard about that." He nodded. "The most famous diplomatic event of Etheria. Limited to princesses, though, right?"

"Yes. And their plus ones," Adora said. Those were the rules.

"No Disney Princesses allowed, though, right?" He laughed again, as did Catra.

Adora frowned. "They're not Etherian princesses," she said. Even if Disney weren't lobbying hard to get some sort of copyright protection in Etheria, they wouldn't be allowed to attend the Princess Prom.

"Right." The Secretary General nodded, growing more serious. "At least, that's a trade dispute and nothing that affects the military."

"Yes." Adora frowned again. Was that a subtle hint? Disney wasn't involved in the military.

"Well, not unless smuggling grows even worse," Catra said. "So far, we haven't found anyone trying to replace military supplies going through the gate with contraband. But I think it's just a question of time before it happens. We couldn't even stop that stuff in the Horde."

"Well, that was the Horde," Adora pointed out. There were a few reasons that the Horde hadn't won the war against the Alliance even before She-Ra had appeared.

Catra snorted.

The Secretary General slowly nodded again. "Well, as long as this stays a trade dispute…" He trailed off.

Adora narrowed her eyes. That definitely wasn't just a random comment. "What do you mean?" she asked.

"Ah, well, I've heard that there are efforts to bring up such matters in the Alliance as part of the military technology transfer." The man shrugged. "I don't think I agree that intellectual property is the same whether it's about media or weapon designs, but some people think so. Or claim to think so."

"What?" Catra blinked. "They want to spread our military technology unless we agree to protect their copyright?"

"We've covered technology transfers in the Alliance treaty!" Adora snapped.

"Yes, of course. But many think any treaty can be renegotiated."

"Over Disney?" Adora shook her head. That was… crazy. Meddling with the Alliance in the middle of a war?

"Disney is merely the most famous such firm, but all media companies have voiced concern over the lack of a treaty regulating intellectual property. And they have the ears of many politicians who depend on their support for their reelection, especially in the United States."

"Back home, we'd call that corruption," Catra commented.

Adora nodded.

"Here, it's politics." The Secretary General shrugged. "In any case, I wanted to let you know, informally, about this."

"Thank you." Adora smiled. She wasn't sure if this was a friendly warning about a potential problem or an attempt to influence her, but now that they knew about this, they could plan how to deal with that.

She looked around for Glimmer and Bow. Ah, there. They were talking with some European politicians - Adora recognised the

German and French foreign ministers. Well, she didn't think Glimmer would mind getting dragged away from the talk there - her friends didn't look like they were enjoying themselves too much.

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, December 31st, 1999

"We made a treaty, and they are trying to go back on their word already because of their elections! That wouldn't happen on Etheria!"

Samantha Carter took a sip from her glass while Glimmer complained. So much for escaping the politics by skipping the Alliance New Year's Eve Party in Brussels. The General must be feeling smug about this.

"Actually," Bow started, "princesses going back on their word isn't unheard of."

"Not when you have a formal treaty!" Glimmer disagreed.

"Well, not on the letter of the treaty, although there are several accounts of treaties being dissolved after the circumstances that caused the treaty to be made changed significantly during the rule of the princesses who made the treaty. But there's often quite the squabbling over things that were not clarified in a treaty," Bow said.

"We made it very clear that our technology was going to be restricted to the Alliance!"

That was true. Sam had studied those parts very thoroughly.

"Well, it's not as if they can actually share our technology," Adora said. "Everyone we talked to in Brussels was clear about that. It's just a way to put pressure on the Princess Alliance about copyright."

“It’s the principle of the thing!” Glimmer shook her head. “They shouldn’t even try that! We’re in an alliance - a military alliance. We didn’t agree anything about trading.”

Daniel cleared his throat. “Well, while that’s technically true, trade is happening - albeit limited to smuggling at the moment. And a lot of the, ah, contraband is media. It’s not surprising that the owners of intellectual property would attempt to stop what they see as theft. You would do the same if, say, stolen goods from Etheira would be sold on Earth, right?”

“Only Earth thinks that copying media is stealing,” Glimmer retorted.

“It’s not like you lose the data you share,” Entrapta chimed in. “Information wants to be free!”

Sam winced. Her friend sometimes picked up the wrong things, or things missing their context, from Earth’s culture. “But not everyone wants to share their data,” she pointed out.

“That’s selfish of them, though.” Entrapta pouted. “I mean, I understand that we can’t share military technology or secrets, but this is media - everyone on Earth has access to it!”

“In theory, maybe,” Daniel retorted. “But not everyone can afford all the media they want.”

“Just like not everyone can afford all the food they need?” Glimmer scoffed. “It’s not a good argument for having copyright. Or for messing with the Alliance to get copyright. Etheria doesn’t do things that way.”

“But Earth does,” Daniel said. “And our system is built on intellectual property being protected - in principle, at least - and copyright protection varies across the world, but a lot of the Earth media wouldn’t be produced if there was no copyright. The investments wouldn’t work out.” He grimaced slightly. “If we returned to the patronage system that we had in the past, we would see a drastic loss of variety in media content. Many patrons

also would only support media that appealed to them or furthered their interests - not an altogether positive change, I think."

That was putting it mildly, in Sam's opinion.

"I've heard complaints that this is happening already as studios and companies limit the creativity of the artists working for them," Bow objected. "And I don't see a significant difference between patrons paying artists for their works and people employing artists to work for them."

"Well, that might have been the case in the studio system in Hollywood, in the past," Daniel said. "And arguably, that is still a valid point for parts of the media business. But not for everyone - between movies, TV shows, literature and music, and arguably video games, you cannot assume everything works the same. Those are different markets."

"And yet, that's what people claim - they say without copyright, everything would crumble," Bow said. "That artists couldn't profit from their works."

"Artists? Disney is a business, not an artist. They just want to make more profits," Glimmer said with a scowl.

"Ugh." Mermista scoffed. "I don't see their problem, anyway. Etheria has fewer people than most of the countries in the Alliance. Why do they care so much about our market?"

Sam took another sip from her drink so she wouldn't correct Mermista. The majority of the Alliance member states were smaller than Etheria's population.

"Fifty million people are still a significant market. And, well…" Daniel smiled. "It's a new market, not saturated, and Earth media is very popular on Etheria."

"And they want magic and magitech," Catra added.

“So, it’s just greed?” Entrapta asked. “They have enough money but want more?”

If the General were here instead of talking with General Hammond, General Haig and General Petit, he would likely make a comment about communist magical space princesses, Sam knew.

“I wouldn’t say that it’s just about money,” Daniel said. “If they tolerate the proliferation of their media on Etheria, some countries on Earth might do the same.”

“Aren’t they doing that already? At least according to what we heard,” Adora asked.

“But in negligible numbers,” Daniel said. “Although that could change now following the development with Russia and China. Trade is one area where both countries could still put pressure on the Alliance - especially if other countries outside the Alliance support them. Such a move could hurt many businesses in the Alliance.”

“Ugh!” Mermista huffed. “If Disney and other businesses try to put pressure on us to avoid pressure from hostile countries, then that sounds like treason to me.”

“I don’t think that would be treason,” Daniel objected. “Certainly not in the USA.”

“Whatever!” Glimmer scoffed again. “It’s clear we need to do something about that. Any ideas?”

Sam winced when she realised that she was being roped into a political planning session. If the General again complained about office politics because of his promotion…

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“Ugh. We should ignore it. They can’t actually force us to do anything; this is just posturing. A tempest in a teapot.”

Mermista had a point, Catra thought. But not much of one. Sure, the Princess Alliance could ignore the complaints from Disney and the other media companies, but as Catra had found out the hard way, ignoring complaints and using force to get what you want was going to end up with you abandoned as soon as people saw an opportunity. "In the short term, yes," she said. "But what happens once the war is over and Earth has adapted to advanced technology?"

Most winced. Entrapta looked confused. "What do you mean?"

"If the threat of the Goa'uld is the only thing that holds the Alliance together, then once that threat is gone, so is the Alliance," Bow said.

"We already knew that," Frosta chimed in. "And if they don't want an Alliance anymore, so what? The Goa'uld will be done by then."

"And we're faced with a planet outnumbering us more than a hundred to one. Half of them already don't like us," Glimmer added with a scowl.

"That's the half that hates the other half, the one in the Alliance, though," Bow said.

Adora nodded.

"There are enough people in the Alliance who dislike us and only go along with the Alliance because the Goa'uld are a threat, and we have the technology they want," Catra said.

"Yes. And we can't count on personal ties to their leaders because they'll be replaced by the next elections," Glimmer added.

"Well, countries often change their leaders without changing their foreign policies," Daniel spoke up. "The United States proved that during the Cold War."

"But they change their policies in response to lobbying and bribes," Catra retorted. "And when it comes to trade, a lot of

money is involved." She might not be an expert on democracy, but that much was clear to anyone who followed Earth news.

"Err, yes, though it's not as clear-cut, and there are many different interests influencing government policy," Daniel replied.

"And how many of those interests are already unhappy with us?" Bow asked. "The bigots. And the religious extremists."

"Those are the same," Glimmer interjected.

"There is some overlap," Bow agreed, "but they are diverse groups."

"And we shouldn't bow to such pressure!" Frosta cut in. "We didn't when we made the Alliance - we drew a line, and anyone who wanted to join us had to respect it! We shouldn't give in now! We have our standards!"

"That was about respecting rights and ending discrimination," Perfuma retorted. "This is just about money. Is that worth making people hate us?"

Adora shook her head. "We can't assume that people will hate us. Many love us."

"Some people worship you. But some people hate us," Catra pointed out. "They just are too weak to hurt us." You couldn't win everyone over.

"Do you honestly expect the rest of the Alliance to turn on us after the war?" Adora asked.

"Attack us? No. But they won't play as nice as they have been playing so far once they don't need us as much any more," Catra replied.

"But we're friends!" Entrapta protested. "Friends don't attack each other. Right, Sam?"

Sam winced at that. “We’re friends, yes. But we’re not leading our country.”

“Your leaders are elected. That’s why we’ve hired Julie and Mr Bown,” Glimmer said. “To show your people that they don’t have to fear us.”

“Yes!” Perfuma nodded emphatically. “And we’ll help Earth with their other problems!”

“Past favours don’t translate into future friendship,” Sha’re said. “Once you are no longer essential to their survival, you become a rival.”

Daniel cleared his throat. “Earth countries don’t really act like the Goa’uld, dear.”

Sha’re shrugged. “Close enough. Who said that countries have interests, not friendships?”

“Probably a democratic leader,” Glimmer muttered. “Freshly elected.”

Catra snickered at that.

“But the Etherians are very popular in key demographics,” Daniel objected. “Even a new government could not ignore that - especially after a victory against the Goa’uld.”

“How many movies with evil princesses will it take to change that?” Catra asked. Propaganda was a thing, after all.

“They wouldn’t go that far, would they?” Perfuma asked, biting her lower lip.

“Not all the way. But a more critical portrayal could be easily done,” Daniel said.

Glimmer scoffed in return. “Whatever. The thing is, we can’t count on the current situation to stay the same. So, we have to do

something about this. Preferably before it turns into a problem."

"Well, the first step to reconcile differences is to talk to each other, find out what everyone wants and see if there's a possible compromise," Daniel said.

"You want us to talk to the media businesses?" Frosta scoffed. "Visit Disneyland?"

"They don't actually do such business in Disneyland," Daniel said. "I think."

"It wouldn't hurt to talk to them. Explain why we don't have copyright," Adora said. "And we need to settle things for the cultural exchange anyway."

"Invite them to a frigate in orbit," Catra said with a grin. "Let them talk to Priest!"

"Catra!" Adora pouted at her.

Catra shrugged. "Not Priest. But they probably haven't been to space yet. It might impress them. Or invite them to Etheria."

"That might set a precedent - annoy us enough and you get preferential treatment," Bow pointed out. "Do we want to risk that?"

"If we start negotiating with Disney, that precedent will be set anyway," Glimmer retorted.

"To be fair, that's a pretty normal thing in business and politics," Daniel said. "The squeaky wheel gets the grease."

"Whatever!" Glimmer repeated herself. "So, we'll talk to a delegation of them, I guess."

Adora nodded, as did the others.

"So… let's rejoin the rest of the party?" Perfuma asked.

"Good idea," Catra agreed. The food wasn't as good as in Brussels, but it was good anyway.

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"It seems our Etherian friends have finished their impromptu meeting," General Haig commented.

Jack O'Neill turned his head and saw that the man was correct. The Etherians, who had secluded themselves with Carter, Daniel and Sha're in a corner of the mess hall in Stargate Command - far more fitting for such a party than the one in Cheyenne Moutain had been, if he was honest - were spreading out again, most of them heading to the buffet. "Looks like it," he said.

Carter and Entrapta were talking animatedly, but judging by their expressions, it wasn't about some new technological marvel (or terror). Entrapta looked upset, and Carter looked guilty, so it was probably something about society - probably Earth's.

Better you than me, he thought as he turned back to the Stargate Command Council. It still felt a bit weird to have the same rank as Hammond. Sure, Jack had thought - with apprehension - about the possibility of ending up in charge of Stargate Command, sometime in the far future, shortly before mandatory retirement, when he wasn't fit to run missions any more, but that had been under the assumption that Hammond would have retired or been promoted away. Not that he minded how things had turned out, of course.

"I wonder what this was about," Petit mused. Though his raised eyebrow clearly showed that he expected Jack to know.

"I wonder why you weren't in the middle of that," Hammond added, rather bluntly, staring at Jack as well.

Because I had the good sense to hide with you lot when everyone was being gathered up, Jack thought. Out loud, he replied: "It's not about military matters, so I wouldn't have been any help." That was his story and he was sticking to it.

"What was it about then?" Haig asked.

"Cartoons," Jack said. "They found out that Disney made a movie about them."

"Ah." Haig nodded

Hammond sighed. "Ah, yes. My grandchildren love it."

"And they probably keep asking you to sneak them to Etheria?" Jack grinned.

Hammond snorted. "They tried to sneak into my shuttle when I visited."

"Bold of them." It seemed his grandkids were quite determined. They might make good special forces recruits in a decade or two, not that Jack would voice that thought. Damn, I shouldn't be thinking about recruiting kids for the military! he added to himself when he saw Frosta grab a drink at the bar. Jack hoped people were, as ordered, watching the teenager's intake, or they might end up with ice sculptures on the runway again. Though, to be fair, with the Russians and Chinese off Stargate Command, traffic to and from the base was dominated by shuttles these days, and they didn't need a runway. Though if she blocked the railways and streets to the port…

Well, it wasn't his problem. He wasn't responsible for drunk princesses. Or for Stargate Command. Just for Alliance Special Forces Command and the war against the Goa'uld.

"I am fortunate that my own family is not quite as brash," Haig said. "Though that might change as they grow older."

"I wouldn't be able to tell." Petit shrugged and glanced at Jack.

Jack returned the shrug. Technically, he had nephews and nieces, but he wasn't really close to his family. 'Don't need an excuse to skip the holiday visit'-'not close', actually. And that was perfectly fine. They had their lives, and he had his.

“Good party,” he commented to change the topic. “Really pulling out all the stops.”

“Within our budget,” Hammond said. “I don’t doubt that the Alliance party was more impressive.”

“It was certainly stuffier,” Jack said. “Too many politicians.” At least he hadn’t had to deal with Kinsey. Apparently, the senator was too busy shmoozing in Washington to attend.

“We answer to them,” Haig said. “So, a good relationship is crucial. Though, as far as I heard, the Tok’ra didn’t attend the party?”

Was everyone pumping him for information? Well, that the Tok’ra were relocating their main base, again, was classified. But there were things he could share. “They had other concerns but sent gifts.” Official ones for the Alliance leadership. And a personal one for him. From Anise. Jack would have to have that thing scanned by Carter to check for anything shady.

“Ah. That was that special delivery, then.” Petit grinned. “Our people scanning the contents looked surprised.”

Jack suppressed a wince. The official gifts had been quite normal - food and artwork. Maybe he should reconsider letting Carter scan his gift. If it was something spicy rather than shady, she might not let him forget it for a long while.

“Aliens have different standards,” Haig said. “Though not too different. Stargate Command received a small sculpture, a carving representing all three of our countries. Quite appealing.”

If you liked wooden animals, Jack thought. They could probably drop it on some display stand in a corner without causing a diplomatic incident. Maybe he should return the favour. Give the Tok’ra something weird that they had to honour lest they insulted their allies…

“It has a certain style,” Hammond politely disagreed. “Although…” he trailed off, frowning. “Are they eating flowers?”

Jack turned and frowned as well. Next to the buffet, a bunch of soldiers were indeed eating flowers. Flowers that Jack was sure hadn’t been present a few minutes ago. But then. Perfuma hadn’t been at the buffet then either, and now she was, beaming at the soldiers.

Soldiers who were quickly going from hesitantly biting the large flowers to enthusiastically munching them. And the flowers kept multiplying.

Jack sighed. He didn’t know what exactly those flowers were, but he knew it was going to be a problem.

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“What did you do?” Adora asked, looking at the brightly-coloured flower in front of her face.

“I changed the flowers here!” Perfuma beamed at her.

“Yeah, we noticed,” Catra commented. “Earth doesn’t have such flowers.”

Adora agreed. The flower was moving, matching her head’s tilting, but that was normal - for an Etherian plant. What wasn’t normal was people were eating those.

“It’s a shame, yes. But maybe we can change that as well.” Perfuma took a bite from the flower she was holding and pouted, then tilted her head, and the flower changed colours. Another bite later, she nodded with a wide smile. “Better!”

“What did you do?” Adora repeated her question. “I mean, what exactly did you do?”

“I made them edible!” Perfuma replied. “And I added all sorts of flavours - colour-coded!”

Catra bit into the yellow flower wriggling next to her, chewed, then blinked. “Beer?”

“Yes! A very popular flavour here!” Perfuma bopped her head.

Adora looked at her friend, then at the various flowers slowly filling the corner next to the buffet - and the soldiers eating them. “How many of the flavours are alcohol?” she asked with a sinking feeling in her stomach.

“Many!” Perfuma was still smiling brightly - and took another bite of her own flower - which had changed colours again when Adora hadn’t been paying attention. “Drugs are illegal, but alcohol isn’t!”

“Hey!” Scorpia approached them, pincers holding a massive flower with a barrell-like blossom. “This is great!” She tilted the flower, and red liquid sloshed inside. “Fruit Punch Flowers!”

“Are there any flowers that aren’t alcoholic?” Catra asked with a snort.

“Yes! I made a soda flower as well! But I can’t make most flavours since those are copyrighted.” Perfuma pouted. “But alcohol is fine! It’s natural!”

Adora took a bite from her flower. It tasted like… whisky. Strong whisky - she coughed.

Perfuma held out her flower - now white - to Scorpia. “Check it out! I made an Ice Liquor Flower!”

“Really?” Scorpia took a bite. “Oh, perfect! Did you show it to Frosta?”

“Not yet! Let’s go find her!”

The sinking feeling in Adora’s stomach, temporarily replaced with the booze she had eaten, returned with a vengeance. Drunk Frosta? They would be lucky if they could recognise the base in the morning! “Wait!”

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, January 1st, 2000

Samantha Carter had expected to spend January 1st dealing with obsolete computer systems suffering from the Y2K 'bug'. A lot of effort had gone into identifying and fixing such systems, but you never got all of them, and the military was rife with old machines that had been kept far longer than expected when they had been installed decades ago.

She hadn't expected that she'd have to delay fixing computer systems in favour of fixing damage to Stargate Command's main base because the New Year's Eve Party had been wilder than expected. A lot wilder.

Apparently, Perfuma had been holding back a lot during her previous visits. And Plumeria's reputation for partying wasn't overblown at all. And Sam had to remember that while Frosta might have been the most obvious concern when it came to drinking due to her age, her temper and her stunt at Thule, she wasn't the only concern when it came to drinking and powers.

"I'm really sorry. It sounded like a good idea at the time."

Sam nodded. Entrapta had meant well. But she had been drunk. "Drinking and science don't mix well."

"So the data indicates. Though we didn't run a blind test."

And they wouldn't do that. Trying to understand what Entrapta had coded after eating half a dozen plants from Perfuma was worse, much worse, than dealing with legacy systems from the 60s. Old computers didn't control construction bots.

As a silver lining, if Sam managed to sort out the coding, Stargate Command's security would be significantly improved. Provided the Generals in charge approved - some of them had looked a bit wary of the automated defences when Entrapta had demonstrated

them last night. Even though that had also ended the question of whether or not they should preserve the flowers Perfuma had created.

"What's done is done," Sam said. Perfuma could recreate the flowers anyway. However, her plans to help Earth by changing plants to improve food production would likely suffer a setback after this.

As would the careers of several soldiers who had started the whole thing by asking Perfuma about parties in her kingdom - Sam was quite sure that they had already been aware of her kingdom's reputation.

But she had a job to do. Sighing, she focused on the screen in front of her again.

"I'm really sorry."

"I know."

At least Adora had taken care of any headaches.

*****

Washington D.C., United States of America, Earth, January 3rd, 2000

"…and as you can see, protecting intellectual property is the key to ensuring a wide range of creative, diverse media. Just as no one would invest in a factory if they could not be assured that its output would not be stolen from them by anyone, no one with a modicum of sense would invest in the production of media if they had no assurances that they would reap the profits of a potential success. Who would spend years working on a book if they would have to watch others steal their work and publish it without remuneration? Intellectual property is property, and violating copyright is theft!"

“We really should have invited them to a frigate in orbit,” Catra muttered as Disney’s lawyer - Mr Patridge or something - rambled on.

“I don’t think that would stop them,” Adora replied in a whisper before she winced a little.

She is probably feeling guilty about not paying complete attention, Catra thought.

“Yes, yes, we've gone through that before. Multiple times,” Glimmer replied. “Etherian legal tradition doesn't agree with that stance. We don't consider it stealing if someone performs a play written by someone else. Or a song. Certainly not if they don't claim to have invented the play or song. The actors and musicians still have to perform.”

“But that leaves the author out in the cold!” the other lawyer protested. “How can they make a profit if everyone can copy their work?”

“Authors generally are paid by their patron,” Bow cut in before Glimmer could snap at the man who had interrupted her. “Some also run plays themselves.”

“Like in the dark ages,” Catra heard the first lawyer whisper. “Shakespeare would feel at home in their world.”

“And as we heard, the publisher or the studio generally profits the most,” Glimmer said.

“They take the financial risk when creating movies and TV shows, so they should also be able to get their fair share of the rewards.” Disney's lawyer smiled. “It's the cornerstone of our industry.”

“Your *industry*.” Glimmer snorted.

“Yes.”

Disney's leader - their CEO - cleared his throat. “I think we've gone over the legal differences more than enough to know where we stand.”

“We knew that before we met today,” Catra said. Why was she here? Except to support Adora and watch Glimmer fume, this was pointless. It wasn't even amusing.

“It is always useful to lay out exactly where each party stands during negotiations,” the first lawyer added.

“Sometimes that's counter-productive,” Glimmer retorted with a toothy smile.

The CEO met her smile. “Indeed. In any case, I don't think we can change our respective legal systems - both seem too entrenched in our respective cultures. But different legal traditions have not been an impenetrable barrier to trade and cultural exchanges on Earth. We have found ways to reach fair agreements despite such obstacles.”

For certain definitions of ‘fair’, Catra thought.

“And you adjusted your own copyright laws when it profited you,” Glimmer said.

“Special cases deserve special treatment,” the second lawyer said. He winced a little when the CEO frowned at him.

“So, what do you have in mind?” Adora asked. “You must have some ideas since you agreed to this meeting.”

“And have yet to offer any sort of compromise,” Catra added under her breath.

“Indeed. While you do not have copyright in Etheria, I believe you do have royal charters and monopolies in many of your kingdoms,” the CEO replied. “For various ventures.”

“Yes.” Glimmer glanced at Adora, Catra saw. That was something they had been discussing. “Like a royal charter to operate certain services. Though while that might be applicable for theatres, it wouldn't help with limiting copies of your media being distributed.”

“We're aware of that. But we have such piracy on Earth as well.”

“Don't let Sea Hawk hear that you call sharing songs piracy,” Catra said. “He might take offence.”

The CEO laughed at that. He obviously didn't know about Etheria's pirates. Some of them might consider this an insult worth drawing steel. Well, not her problem.

“We can tolerate a certain amount of such piracy,” he went on, “as long as it's not too much.”

“The way your media is spreading, I think we're past that point,” Glimmer said. She didn’t seem to be sad about it.

“That depends. You mainly consume our media on tablets like this one, right?” the CEO pointed at Bow's tablet.

“Yes?” Bow tilted his head.

“While certainly a fine piece of technology, the experience it offers is still somewhat… limited compared to a theatre or a live concert.”

Ah. They had gone over that in preparation for this.

“You want a monopoly for such concerts and theatres?” Glimmer asked.

“It would be one way to provide us with fair compensation. Though we do not need a monopoly as long as we're allowed to operate - I am confident that we can provide experiences that will outshine any competition.” The CEO smiles. “Our parks and other venues are quite unique.”

“That would help Disney, of course, but many of my clients would not profit from that,” the second lawyer objected. “Authors and songwriters, for one.”

“Well, those could be compensated by a copyright collective collecting and distributing tariffs on certain media or devices. We have such collectives in many countries to handle similar situations - it's one way to counter the effects of piracy.”

Glimmer frowned. “You want to *tax* our people?”

Catra whistled. That was a hot button for any princess. Well, for Earth as well - they had started revolutions over that.

The CEO raised his eyebrows, seemingly surprised by her reaction, then glanced at the wincing lawyer once more.

“I don't think ‘taxes’ would be the best word for it. It's more like an additional cost added to devices that facilitate the sharing of copyrighted media,” the lawyer said.

“That's effectively a tax!” Glimmer retorted.

“Or think of it as the kingdom paying a flat sum to the authors and musicians whose works are shared freely amongst your people - like a patron supporting an author,” the other author suggested. “Just many authors in this case.”

That was a smoother way to word it, but it didn't change the proposal - Disney and the other firms involved wanted someone to pay for the media everyone back home was sharing.

“And in exchange, you would officially void any further copyright claims?” Glimmer asked.

The CEO inclined his head. “We wouldn't pursue further financial claims, provided we can get a fair agreement.”

“That's just one part of the issue,” Bow pointed out. “What about our artists using copyrighted media?”

The CEO didn't wince, but his expression grew rather stony.

Catra sighed. This was going to take a while.

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Holiday Season Part 4

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, January 4th, 2000

Jack O'Neill frowned at the 'no plants allowed' sticker on the door to his office. "Someone's trying to be funny," he muttered while he ripped it off. He wasn't planning to have plants in his office - he wasn't the kind of officer who would have his aide water his plants as part of their duties, and he couldn't bother with caring for plants himself. But this was about the Stargate Command New Year's Eve Party.

Shaking his head, he entered.

"Good morning, sir!" His aide nodded at him.

"Morning, Brown."

"The urgent paperwork is on your desk, sir."

Jack frowned and suppressed a sigh. "Anything important?"

"General Naird wanted to know what measures are being taken to, I quote, 'prevent another drug-fuelled diplomatic incident'," Brown went on.

"Tell him that that is up to Stargate Command. The Alliance isn't responsible for the Stargate."

"Yes, sir. Admiral Kearsy filed a complaint about the incident as well."

The jerk was probably just jealous that he hadn't been invited to the party. Jack knew those hypocrites too well. "So, he's even dumber than I thought."

"Sir." Brown's slow nod showed he didn't quite agree with Jack's comment.

“I am aware that he’s trying to save his butt by blaming me for everything that went wrong, Lieutenant,” Jack told him. “But this is stupid. I am not a member of Stargate Command any more. I was just a guest at their party.”

“He is blaming Major Carter, sir.”

“What?” Jack narrowed his eyes. That idiot was going after Carter? Jack would bury him. Alive, if he could pull it off.

“He claims she was present in an official capacity since she was helping with their computer systems, temporarily dispatched, and so should have upheld regulations.” Brown handed him a file.

“The guy’s losing it. Blaming a major for not doing a general’s job?” Jack shook his head. “That’s not how we do things in the Alliance.”

“Should I schedule a meeting with the Supreme Commander?”

“What? No, no! I’ll handle that myself.” They couldn’t have Adora squash every petty officer plotting against them. That would only give more ammunition to such people. And she was busy supporting her friends with that copyright stuff. No, Jack would have to do a little character assassination himself. Fortunately, he knew where a number of bodies were buried. “Hold my calls for a while unless it’s an emergency.”

“Yes, sir.”

Jack nodded again and entered his office. The coffee maker was, as expected, running already, courtesy of Brown. Jack took a cup and sat down at his desk. First, do the urgent paperwork so his people were taken care of. Then he’d deal with Kearsy.

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“...and yes, I agree that Admiral Kearsy’s behaviour has cast doubt on his ability to fulfil his duties,” Jack said. “Though I wouldn’t presume to judge the impact of his appalling attitude on

our diplomatic relations with our allies, I can say that he seems to have trouble respecting our chain of command," Jack said.

"I see. I'll look into this. We can't have our officers overreaching like that - it's already incredibly difficult to run the Alliance! Thank you, General."

"Yes, sir."

"Have a nice day, General."

"You too, sir."

Jack leaned back and stretched his arms while he sighed. That had taken longer than expected. Mostly because everyone he had called had used the opportunity to discuss something else. But between the brawl incident and Kearsy's doubling down on his religious attitude and the recent attempt to attack Carter - Earth's best scientist, which meant the moment she quit the service, she could write her own ticket pretty much everywhere, including Etheria - the idiot's career should be done for. And Jack hadn't even had to use some of his blackmail material.

He grabbed a soda from his fridge and switched his TV on - he had earned a break before he dealt with the regular paperwork.

"...and, and I am just speculating here, mind you, but… What if the pagan religions weren't the only religions founded by aliens, Joe?"

"Ah, Frank, I don't think it was established that the Goa'uld founded the Egyptian religion. Dr Jackson was clear about that - they might have impersonated native gods; we just lack documentation of that time period."

"We can ask the Goa'uld who were around back then."

"I don't think we can trust them."

"Good point. Anyway, it doesn't matter since we have records going back two thousand years. And we know there's some Goa'uld masquerading as the devil out there. So, what if Jesus was a Goa'uld as well? What he did in the Bible could have been replicated by alien technology.

"But the Goa'uld were driven out thousands of years before Christ, Frank!"

"I guess the snakes that were captured on Earth didn't get the memo, then, Joe."

"Those are rumours, Frank."

"They were confirmed by our Supreme Commander, She-Ra."

"She said she couldn't comment."

"Exactly! If there were no snakes captured on Earth, wouldn't she have said that? You think that woman can lie worth a damn?"

"Well…"

Jack turned the TV off and cursed. He really didn't want to deal with this right now. Or ever.

Before he could finish his soda, someone knocked on the door. "Yes?" Jack asked. This better be good.

Brown stuck his head inside. "General, the Tok'ra have contacted us. They claim to have crucial information that requires urgent action."

Jack blinked before he grinned. If the Tok'ra wanted urgent action, then it had to be good.

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, January 4th, 2000

The soldiers standing guard in the gate room snapped to attention when Adora walked down the ramp, and General Hammond saluted her. “Supreme Commander, welcome to Earth.”

“General.” She returned the salute. The troops guarding the Stargate were not in her chain of command, but that was rapidly becoming a technicality, now that they were exclusively made up of American, British and French forces - all members of the Alliance. “Have the Tok’ra arrived yet?”

“Not yet,” he replied as he fell in at her side. “It seems you’ve beaten them here.”

“Hah!” Catra snorted behind her.

“We can’t exactly start without them, so it’s meaningless if we’re here first,” Glimmer said.

“But they could start without us. Don’t tell me you’d like that,” Catra retorted.

“If they’re early, Anise will just spend the time trying to convince Jack to donate his genes,” Glimmer shot back.

General Hammond looked surprised - and perhaps concerned; Adora didn’t know him well enough to tell. She cleared her throat. “They’re joking about that. Anise has accepted that Jack doesn’t want to, ah…”

“...make a baby with her,” Catra finished for her.

“That’s not an euphemism for sex, by the way!” Entrapta chimed in. “They could have a baby with one of our artificial wombs if they wanted. Which Jack doesn’t.”

“And Anise does,” Catra added.

They reached the meeting room reserved for the Alliance. Isa and Campbell were standing guard outside, Adora noted. Both stood at attention as well, though Isa’s stinger almost scratched the

ceiling as she did so - the base wasn't really built for people her size.

Inside, Jack and the others - Daniel, Sha're, Teal'c and Sam - were already seated at the table, together with General Naird and Admiral Brown-Emerson. There was no sign of Admiral Kearsy, even though Adora hadn't spoken to anyone yet about the man.

"Sam!" Entrapta pushed past her and beamed at her friend.

"Supreme Commander." Naird nodded at her. "We've received a message from the Tok'ra about wanting to meet us earlier today for an urgent matter. They didn't choose to add any specifics."

Adora knew that already. And she had received the message on Etheria through the network, probably before Naird had. But it would be rude to point that out.

"Yeah, we've already been informed." Catra, of course, had no such qualms. She sat down in her usual chair next to Adora while Naird seemed to deflate.

"Yep," Jack added. "So, anyone want to bet on what it is? Rescue op, sabotage or planetary invasion? I've got five bucks and a jello riding on rescue op."

"General!" Sam hissed.

He grinned in response while Naird looked shocked, and Brown-Emerson… barely reacted. The British officer remained unflappable.

"Whatever it is, the Alliance Navy is ready to do its duty," he said. "Though if it's a planetary invasion, we will have to do with repurposed Horde frigates as transports since our dedicated transports are not yet ready."

"We'll manage," Jack replied.

He was pretty optimistic, Adora thought. Then again, they had liberated one planet already, so they had done this before. Still… She couldn't help worrying a little. They were still building up various units and weapon systems. They could launch an offensive, of course, but they would have to rely on the Horde fleets and NATO ground forces almost exclusively. And that would mean more weaknesses to cover. More casualties being taken.

"I think it's a sabotage mission," Glimmer said. "Probably another research station we need to take out and blame someone else for."

That sounded plausible as well.

"Naw. They could do that themselves," Catra disagreed.

"Do you think it's going to be a bigger operation?" Bow asked. "An invasion?"

Catra shrugged. "Could be anything - the Tok'ra are good at spying, but they don't have the numbers for anything bigger. But if it's urgent, I think it's not going to be an invasion. On the other hand, any raid runs the risk of exposing the Alliance, and the Tok'ra are big on secrecy."

"We don't have enough data to tell!" Entrapta piped up.

"Whatever it is, we can handle it," Glimmer said.

"And it's going to be easier than dealing with copyright and media corporations," Catra added with a snort.

"Whoever gave businesses the same rights as people made a huge mistake!" Glimmer muttered.

"Well, it's actually…" Daniel began before he was interrupted by General Hammond escorting the Tok'ra into the room.

Garshaw of Belote/Yosuf, Anise/Freya, Lantash/Martouf and Jakar/Mats.

Yes, this was going to be big, Adora knew.

*****

"After his humiliation at the hands of the Alliance, Apophis is trying to recover his standing - but so many rivals are moving against him, his forces are stretched thin. And the loss of his queen has hurt his reputation even more, as he needs a new source of Prim'tas for his Jaffa."

Samantha Carter glanced at Sha're when Garshaw mentioned Amauntet. The woman was staring straight at the screen in the meeting room, but Sam could see that Daniel was squeezing her hand. Sam knew exactly how the other woman was feeling - Lantash/Martouf's presence reminded her of her own possession.

"And to snack on," the General added with a scoff.

Sam didn't know if he had said that to draw attention from Sha're - Sam hadn't been the only one looking at her - but if he had, he had succeeded; most of the room was frowning at him.

And Catra made a retching noise.

Garshaw cleared her throat and continued the briefing. "Yet, according to our best operatives, Apophis has already managed to replace his queen. He struck a deal with the Goa'uld queen Taweret."

Sam clenched her teeth. That was bad news - she had hoped that Apophis would take longer to replace his queen.

"What kind of deal did he offer her?" the General asked. "Did he make her an offer she couldn't refuse?"

"We don't know the details - that was between him and her, apparently," Garshaw replied. "But we do know that he has, despite the pressure on his realm, dispatched a sizeable part of his reserves to serve and protect her while she is building a new base in secret."

“And you found the secret base?” Glimmer sounded eager.

“We have operatives in that fleet. As soon as they manage to report back, we’ll know where Tawaret is hiding. We do know the general area in which they departed, though.”

A map appeared floating above the table with a highlighted section near Apophis’s realm.

“That could be a ruse, though,” Catra said.

“Yes, it could. But Apophis is under great pressure. He cannot waste too much travel time.”

“It seems strange that he would send so many of his ships to protect a secret base,” Teal’c commented. “It would be more effective to keep her at his side and have his personal guard protect both of them. Doubly so with his rivals coming at him from all sides.”

“Exactly,” Garshaw said. “While this could be an attempt of Tawaret to emphasise her worth to him, she would be aware of his current circumstances and know that those would weaken her new partner. So, whatever they are planning likely goes beyond mere protection and is worth the risk of losing more worlds.”

“He could be using this to make his rivals fear a deep strike into their territory,” Adora pointed out.

“That is a possibility, but given his enemies’ past behaviour, they are more likely to retaliate with such strikes themselves. And some might think it’s a bluff and test him if they hear about it. Our operatives believe that we cannot ignore the potential threat of this secret operation.”

“Great. Even when he’s losing, he’s making trouble,” the General muttered.

“Do you have an estimate on the composition of this force?” Adora asked.

“Predominantly Ha’taks in sizeable numbers,” Garshaw said. A moment later, more data appeared on the screen.

Catra whistled. “That’s enough to take a planet.”

“Indeed. But it is not a raiding force,” Teal’c added.

“Yep. So… we need a bigger task force. Just in case,” the General said.

“We don’t need to match them ship for ship, though, not with the gap in capability,” Admiral Brown-Emerson pointed out.

“Overwhelming force reduces our own casualties, though,” Nairdobjected.

“That depends on the operation’s goal,” Garshaw said. “Each world we liberate risks exposing the Alliance to the Goa’uld Empire.”

“And you just want to wreck whatever they are planning and take out Taweret,” Catra said.

“Yes. If we can destroy both the fleet and the queen, Apophis might not recover from the blow,” Garshaw said. “And if he loses a costly project…”

Catra flashed her teeth in a grin. As did the General, Sam noted.

“Unless it’s a bluff, and he’s just setting up his new queen on a deserted planet in the middle of nowhere while everyone prepares for a sneak attack that never launches,” Glimmer said. “How many of his rivals will risk being left open to such an attack by striking first?”

“Heru’ur would,” Jakar cut in.

“Indeed. Though since he would be leading the attack, he would not be at as much risk as a System Lord staying in his capital,” Teal’c added. “Something Apophis will take into account.”

“And their shared defeat during their false flag operation has made all System Lords involved more cautious,” Anise added.

“So, we need to send a task force to Apophis’s realm so it’s ready to strike as soon as we get the word,” the General summed up.

“Yes,” Garshaw said. “The sooner it’s in position, the smaller the chance that we lose our window of opportunity. Our people are risking their lives for this.”

“And we won’t let them down,” Adora said, nodding firmly.

*****

Earth Orbit, January 7th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“I feel guilty for not helping with the Earth media companies. If only the cultural exchange program weren't stalled! The artists we contacted must feel so disappointed by us; all that talk and planning, and now it's not going forward until we've sorted out the copyright issue.”

Looking through the shuttle window down at Earth below them, Catra rolled her eyes at Adora's comment. Leaving that mess to others - not that it was Adora's mess to begin with, anyway; she wasn't a ruling princess - was a great thing in Catra's opinion. “You've slept maybe ten hours in the last three days organising this deployment,” she pointed out. “If anyone has no right to feel guilty, it's you.”

“I wasn't alone!” Adora protested. “Jack and the others worked as hard! You didn't sleep much either!”

Catra shrugged. “I could take naps anytime I wanted.” One of the perks of being a cat. Next to looking hot, being agile, flexible and graceful, and having claws to rip anything short of a spaceship to shreds.

“That's not enough to replace a good night's sleep,” Adora retorted. Catra lifted her eyebrows at her lover, and Adora blushed

in embarrassment in return. “I'm the Supreme Commander. The buck stops with me, as Jack said.”

“He said that about himself when you asked him to take a break,” Catra corrected her.

“The principle is the same!”

Catra snorted. Adora was a work in progress. Too responsible for her own good. At least Catra had had the good sense not to take an official position in the Alliance. She could help out where she was needed without being bogged down by duties.

And she had had to help out a lot during the last three days. Moving an entire landing division’s worth of troops and Jack's Special Forces on a moment's notice had thrown the Alliance staff into chaos. For all the Earth armies’ training, they hadn't been quite ready for such a move. Jack had called it a ‘learning experience’. Next time, things would be better - provided they could keep a reaction force ready to get going at all times. That kind of readiness would tie up a decent chunk of their forces, including logistics, and affect training times as well - the time a unit spent getting ready for instant deployment to relieve the current reaction force was time spent not training other things, after all. On the other hand, it was good training for their logistics…

Adora was pouting, Catra noticed. “Hm?” she asked her lover as innocently as she could - some lessons had to be driven home, after all, if she was to keep Adora from working herself sick.

Adora frowned at her in return. “I also feel it's a bit unfair that we won't be travelling with the task force.”

“We'll join them through the closest Stargate once they are in the area of operations,” Catra pointed out. As they had agreed to days ago.

“But the entire force will be stuck in the ships for weeks while we just… skip it all.”

“And we worry about the war, politics and the economy while they get to laze around in their transports,” Catra shot back. Then she cocked her head to the side and grinned. “You know what? Going along with the force sounds like a great idea!”

“Catra!” Adora frowned at her. “It's not about that! We can't just leave for weeks. But those people won't be able to visit their families for months!”

“They knew that when they signed up for this.” And the soldiers were volunteers. At least the American and British troops. The French and Germans still had conscription, but they were still better motivated than the average Horde troops, in Catra's experience.

Meanwhile, their shuttle had reached the task force gathered in orbit and was flying past the rows of frigates towards their flagship.

“Still…” Adora glanced at the pad in her hand.

“You don't have to read the whole speech,” Catra told her. “Just tell them to do their best or something.” Adora was best when speaking honestly, anyway.

“But my staff worked hard on this.”

“And you don't feel comfortable reading it. So don't.” Catra shrugged. Adora needed to be more selfish - and more honest - to be happy.

Adora frowned some more, then slowly nodded. “You're right.”

“Just blame me when the paper pushers complain,” Catra told her with a grin.

“Catra! I won't let you take the blame for my decisions!”

“I told you to do it, didn't I?”

“But it was still my decision! My responsibility.”

Never change, Adora, Catra thought as they set down in the frigate's hangar, where the commanders of the various units making up the task force were already waiting for them. Well, for the Supreme Commander of the Alliance.

Catra thought about taking a nap in the shuttle, but only for a moment. She wasn't going to leave Adora alone here.

Besides, hearing her improvised speech should be interesting.

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, January 15th, 2000

As he stood in the lift carrying him down inside Stargate Command, Jack O'Neill couldn't help feeling a little conflicted about the whole situation he found himself in. On the one hand, it was a good thing that the Tok'ra had come through with more intel - an actual breakthrough - so quickly, barely a week after their first revelation about Apophis's mysterious troop and queen movement. Thanks to some careless Goa'uld underling in charge of logistics who had been a bit too clever with anticipating supply runs and had tried to pre-position a freighter for the fleet before Apophis had squashed that and the underling, they now knew the task force's destination: PU-9624. Apparently, not even the Goa'uld had named the system yet.

On the other hand, the Alliance task force would take a few more weeks until it could reach the planet. Jack would have really preferred if they could actually act on the so conveniently actionable intel they got. They didn’t even have spy bots in the system yet, though those little buggers were closer than the flotilla and should make contact in ten days.

Then there was the fact that the system wasn't as close to Apophis's realm as they had expected - it was pretty far away, actually. Past the fringes of the Goa'uld Empire, in what had been

a buffer zone between the snakes and Horde Prime. There was nothing about it in the data banks of all three former Horde fleets in the Alliance, but that didn't have to mean anything; Horde Prime apparently kept far too much information to himself. For a ruthless dictator with an army of clones made in his image and conditioned from birth - if you could call popping out of a pod birth - to be utterly loyal to him, the man had been very paranoid. Not unjustified, given Hordak's example, but still.

In any case, it meant that the closest Alliance assets to PU-9623 were actually the combined First and Second Fleet forces on Etheria, a mere two weeks away from the system. Which was good for a rapid reaction, but entirely too close to Etheria for Jack's comfort.

However, that also meant that they could wipe out the entire snake force and have decent odds that Apophis would blame it on some Horde attack and not the Alliance and hopefully stay away from the former Horde Empire, which was good news. And yet, that the damn snake risked a sizeable part of his fleet in what the analysts agreed was an area of space the snakes generally avoided was not good - Jack wasn't an analyst, but he was sure the snake hadn't picked the system just because it was obscure and his rivals might be scared off.

There was something there. Something important. But not important enough to have a Stargate, apparently - Carter had looked through all their data and hadn't found an address. So, the Alliance scouting force would have to travel to the system by ship from Etheria.

And without much ground support. In theory, they could send another division through the Stargate to Etheria and load it up in the frigates there. But just transporting everything to and through the gate and then loading it all up in ships and flying to another planet would take so long, the force already underway would reach the system faster than that.

The Alliance really needs more fast reaction forces at brigade or division size, Jack thought as he stepped out of the lift and saluted the guards there. The Navy pukes had been quick to propose stationing marines on all ships for such situations, but Jack had managed to shoot that stupidity down. This wasn't 1812 any more; soldiers needed far more supplies and support on the ground to be effective in war. Light infantry wouldn't cut it - and for situations where light infantry was good enough, they already had Jack's people who could be deployed through the Stargate and on any ship that could carry them. All the Navy's proposal would do was waste manpower by having marines twiddle their thumbs on Horde frigates on the off-chance that they might be needed one day.

He entered the gate room. The sight of the Stargate brought back memories. Once more, Jack and his friends would step through the gate and risk their lives scouting alien planets and foiling the plans of snakes. But this time, it wouldn't just be SG-1.

"Jack!" Daniel smiled at him. Sha're and Teal'c both merely nodded. "We're ready. Sam's already on Etheria."

He knew that already. Carter was helping to set up the transports on Etheria - and, most importantly, the stealth shuttle they would need for the final leg of the mission.

"General." Burke's grin turned the rank into a slight tease. He was standing with his team - Jones, Müller and a new guy, Dupont. Good people. Jack had trained them personally. They would do well.

But Jack wasn't quite so sure about the other addition to this mission. "Jakar." He nodded at the Tok'ra spy.

"General O'Neill." The snake smiled at him and nodded back.

At least Jakar wasn't Anise. That would have been creepy.

Jack looked at everyone, then nodded once again. "Alright! Dial Etheria! We've got a mission to run for the Alliance."

*****

Outside the PU-9623 System, January 28th, 2000

"...and our spy bots have tracked the enemy ships. Their numbers closely match up with our intel, though we're missing one Ha'tak in the system - it's not on the planet, either."

Adora nodded at Sam's explanation as she looked at the holoprojection floating in the middle of the briefing room in WrongHordak's flagship. It was a simple system, as Entrapta called it - three planets, one of them habitable, the other two gas giants. No pretty rings around either of them, though they were useful to gather resources to build spy bots here

"But! There are a few debris fields in the system," Entrapta cut in. "We haven't run detailed scans yet to check if one of them matches the missing ship's mass since the spy bots couldn't get close enough without showing up on the Goa'uld sensors. We really should have covered this with stealth bots, but they wouldn't have arrived before us, so it was deemed pointless to re-route the closest ones."

"Debris fields?" Jack asked with a frown. "Multiple ones?"

"Yes!"

"Potential remains of a space battle, General," Sam said. "Though we don't have enough data yet to tell how old they are."

"We have no records of this system in our memory banks," WrongHordak said. "But it's close to the border of Horde Prime's old empire, so it should have been visited at least once by a scouting force."

Adora nodded. And couldn't help thinking that it was nice to talk to Clones who didn't literally worship her.

"Yes," Entrapta said, frowning. "Horde Prime really should have shared all his data with all of you. That was very inconsiderate of

him!”

“Never expect your enemy to be stupid,” Jack commented. “So… any signs of battle damage on the rest of the fleet?”

“Nothing that we could detect, sir,” Sam replied. “Although there seems to be exotic radiation in the system that degrades the performance of our long-range sensors.”

“That might be the reason - or one reason - that Apophis picked this system,” Bow speculated. “It would make detecting his fleet even harder.”

“It also makes detecting enemy scouts harder since his sensors would be affected as well,” Sam objected.

“What kind of exotic radiation, Carter? I am not looking forward to becoming a mutant,” Jack joked. Probably joked.

“We have yet to identify the radiation, sir.”

“It’s a mystery!” Entrapta beamed. “We need to get closer to get better readings, anyway - of the ships and the radiation. So far, we've only managed to confirm that it exists because of its effect on our sensors, but no direct readings.”

“So, we could develop mutant powers if we fly into the system?” Jack asked, raising his eyebrows. He was still looking serious, Adroa noted.

“That is very unlikely,” Sam told him. “Apophis’s fleet would have been exposed for weeks, and his Jaffa should have been affected by it.”

“Maybe that’s why he sent them here.” Jack grinned. “Create mutant super-Jaffa.”

“Apophis would not risk a sizeable part of his fleet for such an experiment, though,” Teal’c spoke up. “He would send chosen

volunteers to be exposed and withdraw his ships to wait for the results."

"And he wouldn't risk his new queen like that," Sha're added. "He would not want to have offspring with mutations."

"We'll still proceed slowly and carefully," Adora said. "Send in a stealth shuttle with more sensors first to take detailed scans. Without a crew," she added. WrongHordak's fleet wasn't worshipping her, but she wouldn't put it past some of them to volunteer as test subjects, so to speak, if it meant they could distinguish themselves.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "The stealth system will affect the readings, but we're still going to have more data!"

Everyone seemed to agree, so Adora finished the meeting and let her friends work. Or nap, in Catra's case.

*****

An hour later, the stealth shuttle was approaching the first gas giant with its scanners primed and its stealth system active. Bow, Sam and Entrapta were practically glued to the screens linked to the sensors while everyone else watched on the big screen in the briefing room.

"Still no sign of the missing ship. But we're closing on the first debris field! Scanning!"

"It looks like… Yes. Those are processed materials. Although they do not match a Ha'tak's hull - they match a Horde frigate's hull."

"So… how old are they?" Jack asked.

"Several hundred years at least. With the system's background radiation, anything more precise will require physical samples," Sam said.

"And what about the radiation?"

“Checking!” Entrapta grinned. “Oh… interesting readings! Very interesting. Oh! We’ve got a match! A partial match! It’s…” She trailed off, and Adora saw that she was biting her lower lip.

“What’s it?” Catra asked.

Entrapta looked actually embarrassed. Or guilty. “It’s the same, well, same-ish, kinda, radiation left behind by the portal experiment we kinda tried back in the Horde.”

Oh.

Adora heard Catra hiss under her breath.

And Glimmer had grown very tense.

The portal experiment that had almost destroyed Etheria, back in the war. The experiment that had needed Queen Angella’s sacrifice to stop.

“It looks like this was the site of an interdimensional displacement,” Sam said, breaking the sudden silence.

*****

Samantha Carter focused on the screen in front of her. She didn't have to glance at the others in the briefing room to read the mood. She wasn't privy to every detail involving that particular incident, but she had caught enough from Entrapta's casual remarks, and from her friend's silences and changes of topics following any such remark, to know the gist of it.

Queen Angella, Glimmer's mother, had sacrificed herself to seal a dimensional portal that had been meant to reshape reality and had ended up threatening to destroy it. It had been a Horde Wunderwaffe, not quite a Hail Mary attempt to win the war - the Horde's position hadn't been that bad yet back then - initiated by Hordak, finished by Entrapta and pushed ahead by Catra, who had been so fixated on it that she banished Entrapta to some death prison island for refusing to continue.

Catra very obviously blamed herself for it, but Entrapta blamed herself for not stopping it (or managing to convince Catra that it was too dangerous), and Sam suspected even Hordak felt guilty about starting the whole project to contact Horde Prime, at least in hindsight.

But she was sure that Adora blamed herself for not stopping the project before someone had to sacrifice themselves to seal the dimensional rift. Even though she probably hadn't had any realistic chance to know, much less reach it in time. Sam hadn't asked - she knew better than poking at such topics - but she was also sure that Adora felt guilty for not sacrificing herself in Angella's place.

And Sam knew that Glimmer's relationship with her mother had been what most people would call 'complicated'. Not too unusual for a teenager, but add the war and survivor's guilt to it…

It was a huge mess, and Sam really didn't want to discuss it. But there was no choice - they couldn't continue with the mission without talking about this. And leaving Apophis to dabble with such forces was entirely out of the question.

She cleared her throat. "We have no idea yet what kind of dimensional displacement, and if successful, took place here. The readings are similar to those gathered by Entrapta in the past, but this might be typical for any such event."

"It doesn't matter," Adora said. "Just the risk that Apophis is building a reality-altering portal is too much. We have to stop him."

"Yeah," the General agreed.

Neither Catra nor Glimmer said anything, nor did Entrapta comment on the science involved - she must be feeling even worse than Sam expected about this. Suppressing a sigh, Sam went on: "We need to gather more data to pinpoint potential sources of this radiation."

“Can this dimensional radiation thingie affect combat operations in the system?” the General asked.

“Not the residue we're picking up,” Sam replied. “But if Apophis's forces are running an experiment that tampers with dimensions, then they might attempt to use that in battle.”

“Like we did,” Catra muttered.

“So, we need to wipe them out before they have the chance to do that - or anything like it,” Glimmer said with a grim expression. “Attack them with overwhelming force.”

Bow cleared his throat, then smiled almost sheepishly. “We should gather more intel first, I think. So we know more about, ah, our targets.”

Glimmer glared at him. “We just crush everything.”

“We should at least find out where Taweret is before we launch an attack,” Sha're added. “We came here to deal with her.”

“That was before we found out that Apophis is trying to mess with dimensions,” Glimmer retorted. “This is more important.”

“We, ah, don't know yet if he's actually experimenting with that technology,” Daniel pointed out. “This might have been an accident or just a coincidence.”

An accident wasn't impossible - hyperspace travel was distantly related to dimensional displacement technology - but unlikely. And the odds of a naturally occurring event that spawned such radiation? Sam wouldn't bet on that, either. Though it would be a fascinating discovery - akin to a weakened spot in the dimensional fabric some people had speculated might exist.

She nodded. “I think we should gather more data before we proceed with any action. We have the enemy fleet under surveillance, and I believe that with the sensors we have in place

now, we should detect any dangerous experiments in time to intervene." Probably.

Glimmer didn't look convinced. "It's still a dangerous risk."

Catra nodded.

But Adora shook her head. "We can't just rush in. We might make things worse by accident. Let's gather more data."

"Alright," Entrapta said. She didn't sound as enthusiastic as she usually did, though, and Sam bit her lower lip.

*****

Outside the PU-9623 System, January 29th, 2000

Samantha Carter glanced at the clock on her screen. It was past midnight. Technically, a new day. And they were still at work. If they were back on Earth, at Stargate Command, the General would check in and tell her to get to bed.

But they were on a mission. A mission that had turned out to be a bit more dangerous, at least potentially dangerous, than they had expected.

And also far more personal than they had expected.

Sam glanced at Entrapta, who was still uncharacteristically silent and serious. She clenched her teeth—she couldn't let this go on.

"So…" she started to say, then trailed off for a second when Entrapta didn't react. "You know it wasn't your fault, right?"

"What wasn't my fault?" Entrapta asked without taking her eyes off the screen.

"The portal on Etheria."

"I built it - well, I finished it after Hordak designed the concept. But I made it work."

Sam shook her head. “But you realised the danger and tried to stop… others from using it.”

“But I failed! I couldn't convince Catra how dangerous it was.”

“I don't think anyone could have,” Sam said. Not according to what she had heard.

“I should have sabotaged the portal in advance! I should have considered this!” Entrapta finally turned to look at Sam, blinking rapidly. “It was my fault.”

You didn’t understand people well enough to know that. Sam didn't say that. That would be unfair. That wasn’t Entrapta's fault either. People without her… issues… were routinely fooled by unhinged but charismatic leaders. That was a common foible of humans. “You did what you could. I doubt anyone else could have managed it either,” she said instead.

Entrapta shook her head. “I’m still responsible! I…”

A beep interrupted her.

Both of them turned to look at the display. New data from a stealth shuttle. Flagged as important.

Sam quickly checked it - and drew a sharp breath. There were large concentrations of Naquadah on the planet. A ship that had landed or crashed? No - all of them were underground. A hidden gate site? But the amount of Naquadah was far too large for a gate.

Sam pressed her lips together and quickly checked other sensors. Power readings. Ground density.

The data matched.

“There's a base on the planet. A large one. And it's active.”

*****

The Secret Base Part 1

Outside PU-9623 System, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra stared at the display floating in the middle of the room. "That's not really detailed," she complained. It really wasn't. It was a very rudimentary 3D-model.

"That's the best we can do with our scanners from orbit," Sam replied. "We extrapolated some structures, but… we'll need a magic scanner close by to get more details." After a moment's pause, she added: "We only got those results after we adjusted the bot's sensors with the data from Alpha."

Catra hissed again. "That's a First Ones base?"

"It's a possibility," Sam replied.

"I don't know what would be worse," Jack said. "Apophis having technology to block our sensors, or Apophis having access to an Ancient base."

"The second," Jakar said. "I consider it most urgent that we take out both his fleet and his base. This takes priority over confirming Taweret's position."

"Yes," Glimmer agreed. "We can't let Apophis get his hands on such a base."

"He might already have his hands on the base," Jack said, pointing at the structures directly above the underground's base. Those were standard Goa'uld fortifications. "You don't throw up that kind of base in a day or two, and that mound next to the base doesn't look natural or old."

"Our scanners don't show a shaft leading to the base," Entrapta objected. "And that would show up - unless he managed to build them using First One materials. Though even then, we should

have detected the effects of such a structure on the surrounding earth and stone."

Jakar nodded. "Yes. Even with our digging technology, we cannot build our bases without leaving such traces. Though detecting them is beyond the standard Goa'uld sensors."

Or so you think, Catra added silently. But that was a discussion for another day.

"They could be using a ring transporter," Sha're pointed out.

"Yes," Sam agreed. "We have to assume they have access to the base, and for a while at least - we don't know when he first discovered this system."

"That makes it even more urgent that we strike as soon as possible," Glimmer said.

"The task force stands ready to launch an attack on the enemy fleet at a moment's notice, Supreme Commander," WrongHordak said. "We are plotting their courses and adjusting our calculations so we can drop on them from hyperspace."

That would ensure they would surprise the Goa'uld - since they could only jam their comms for a short while and couldn't block them from entering hyperspace, that was essential if they wanted to take the Goa'uld out without allowing them to alert Apophis by comms or couriers. But it was dangerous. The risk of colliding with an enemy ship upon exiting hyperspace was low - though not zero - but the task force would be dropping into knife-fighting range. Even technologically inferior ships were dangerous at such ranges.

But that wasn't Catra's primary concern. "Even if we take out the fleet in the system, the base will be able to react."

"We can destroy them from orbit," Glimmer retorted.

“Quickly enough to stop them from contacting Apophis? Or activate a Stargate they might have?” Catra shook her head.

“We don’t have the planet in our data banks,” Sam said. “But they could have brought one to the planet.”

“Apophis probably doesn’t want to spend weeks on every booty call,” Jack said.

“He would not want to leave Taweret so far out of his reach, lest she might turn the forces guarding her,” Teal’c agreed. “He would want to be able to reach her - or have her reach him - through a Stargate. Though that could be inside the base or in the flagship of the fleet - either offers advantages and disadvantages for him.”

If he had the Stargate on a ship, it would allow him better control over it - and over the ship’s crew. But he would need a shuttle or a ring transporter to reach the base. And more people would know when he arrived - or Taweret took off. And Catra had a feeling that Apophis would want direct access to the base. It just seemed to fit the snake better.

“Even if they do escape, they’ll report that a Horde fleet attacked them. Apophis has no reason to suspect the Alliance,” Glimmer pointed out.

“Yes. But if we just destroy the base, we won’t know what they worked on there - and whether or not they managed to flee with completed projects,” Catra said.

“And Taweret would escape,” Sha’re said.

Jakar slowly nodded. “Yes, I think we should ascertain what kind of research they are doing in the base. And whether or not it is functional.”

Adora nodded. “Yes. We don’t want them to panic and open a portal to another dimension.”

Catra clenched her teeth. That had been her lowest point. She had almost destroyed Etheria - killed everyone - through her obsession. If there was a risk that Apophis was working on a similar project… "We need to find out what they're doing there - and stop it." Permanently.

Adora nodded again. "And we need to take the base and destroy their fleet at the same time." She looked at WrongHordak. "This will require close coordination."

"And a trip in a stealth shuttle," Jack added as WrongHordak saluted Adora.

*****

PU-9623 System, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Enemy patrol approaching."

Adora turned her head to look at the screen in front of her at Sam's report. Yes, there was a patrol of two Death Gliders on a course that would take them closer to the shuttle. Not very close, though - certainly not near enough to risk a collision. And with the stealth generator active, they had no chance to spot the shuttle either.

She still tensed up for the next few minutes while the two Death Gliders passed the shuttle. She trusted her friends with her life, and she knew the stealth shuttle worked, but you could never be completely sure.

"I feel like I'm in a submarine with a destroyer passing above us on the surface," Catra whispered.

"We're not in a submarine," Jack, predictably, complained. "This is a stealth shuttle."

Adora frowned at Catra - she was sure that her lover had just said that to rile up Jack.

“Feels like a submarine running silent,” Catra retorted.

“It’s more like a stealth fighter. Submarines don’t fly,” Jack said.

“Stealth fighters generally don’t transport more than a pilot. Unless it’s a movie,” Daniel pointed out.

“We don’t talk about that movie!” Jack snapped.

“What movie?” Sha’re asked.

“A stupid action movie made by a guy who had no idea about planes!”

“A popcorn flick.”

“I believe they are talking about ‘Executive Decision’.”

“We aren’t talking about that movie, Teal’c!”

“My mistake then.”

Catra snorted. “We really need to watch that at the next movie night. It sounds like a riot.”

“No, we don’t!” Jack protested.

“I believe I can acquire a copy for such an occasion.”

“I think we have that movie on file somewhere,” Bow added. “We have a lot of military movies on file to, ah, study.”

“It’s not a military movie. It’s a disgrace.”

Adora looked at Catra. “What kind of movie is it?”

Catra shrugged. “I never watched it. I only know Jack hates it.”

“Any Air Force member hates it!”

"Ah, Jack, I don't think that's correct. I am sure there are at least a few airmen and officers who like the movie despite any, ah, artistic liberties the producers might have taken." Daniel smiled a bit apologetically.

"There's nothing artistic about that movie! They…"

"The Death Gliders have passed," Sam reported.

"...right. Continuing towards our destination."

Adora looked at the screen again. The system's habitable planet was coming up. Too far away still to spot with the naked eye, but the sensors were covering it already. And updating their information.

"Two Ha'tak's in orbit. One geostationary over the base, the other above the planet's north pole," Sam summed up.

"Weird arrangement," Catra commented. "What good is the one at the pole?"

"We don't know. There's nothing on our scanners in that area," Entrapta said. "It's… Oh!"

"'Oh'?" Adora winced. When Entrapta sounded like that, it usually wasn't good news.

"Look at the power readings, Sam!"

"Oh! Those are… I didn't think a Ha'tak had so much power available," Sam said.

"They don't," Entrapta said. "At least, they can't generate so much power. But…"

"...they can receive so much power from the ground," Sam finished for her. "From the base."

“Microwave-based power transfer? But our scanners would show that…”

“Something similar, probably. There is feedback on another frequency… Look at this readout!” Bow cut in.

“Oh!”

Again! Adora twitched.

“So, what is going on?” Catra bluntly asked.

“Oh! It looks like the base is feeding a lot of power to the Ha’tak above it. The readings are getting clearer as we close in,” Entrapta replied. “Look at the stress the ship’s suffering!”

“Those vibrations aren’t good for its structural integrity,” Sam agreed.

“But why are they doing this?” Bow asked.

“It’s a test,” Sam said. “They’re testing power transfers.”

“What for?” Jack asked before Adora could ask the same.

“Possibly as an experiment, sir,” Sam told him.

“Related to the dimension travel thing?”

“We have yet to confirm that, sir.”

Bow nodded. “They’re testing power transfer. What are the odds that they are testing a new weapon system as well?”

“Oh! Like a dimensional cannon? Ripping open a dimensional rift to damage your target? Or move it into a pocket dimension like Despondos?” Entrapta perked up.

“If they are experimenting with a weapon like that, we must stop them at all costs!” Glimmer snapped.

“And we need their data to know what they have done so far.”

“Proceed,” Adora said. “But avoid the Ha’tak - and don’t fly through the area below it.” She didn’t feel like risking being imprisoned in another dimension. Like Angella…

“Yeah, that wouldn’t be a smooth ride,” Jack said as he changed course. “Would be damn embarrassing if we get taken out by accident without the snakes meaning to attack us. We could never live that down.”

“I think the more important problem is that we wouldn’t survive it in the first place, Jack.”

“Power spiking!” Sam snapped.

A moment later, the shuttle’s alerts went off, and Adora’s screen flickered - followed by the entire shuttle shaking.

“That was… a multidimensional release of power,” Entrapta reported. “I think.”

“A what?” Jack asked with clenched teeth. Several of the alerts on his display were still lit, Adora saw.

“They vented that power into what might have been an attempt to create a rift, sir. That’s only a hypothesis, though.”

“Great. Whatever it was, it played haywire with our systems. The Stealth generator was just flagged as damaged. Won’t last much longer.”

Adora drew a sharp breath. They were too close to the enemy to withdraw easily. Too close to the planet to survive another. She could call in the task force, but that would leave the base untouched during the attack. And they were so close… “Take us down in the target area. Quickly.”

They would continue with the mission.

*****

PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

They entered the atmosphere at high speed. Not quite dangerous, not fast enough to risk losing control, but it was a rougher ride than recommended and would require a thorough maintenance check afterwards, according to the manual even though the inertial compensators of the craft did their job.

Samantha Carter knew that very well since she had written part of the manual for the stealth shuttles and knew its specs by heart.

Not that the craft wouldn't have gone into maintenance anyway, what with the damage it suffered because of its proximity to whatever experiment Apophis - or Taweret - was running on the planet. Entraptra, Bow and herself were struggling to keep the stealth generator running while they plunged towards the planet's surface. Between the stealth field and the effect from the radiation released by the dimensional venting on all sensors, they would hopefully remain undetected - Sam had charted a course that had them on the side opposite to the base for the re-entry and on the southern half of the planet so the thermal effects of the manoeuvre would not be too obvious to any close observer.

But there was always a risk, and they would have to find a hiding spot for the shuttle - one close to the base so they could reach it on foot. The special coating and shielding could only do so much, and Sam didn’t think that Apophis had sent Jaffa to this planet who were lax in their duties.

So, while the General brought the shuttle down, she left handling the sputtering systems of the shuttle to her friends and focused on the sensors, scanning the area near their target for caves and valleys with cliffs. Anything big enough to hide the shuttle from above. She already had an earlier overview from the spy bots and the shuttle's sensor readings on approach, but that was not up to date and left a lot of area to cover,

The shuttle levelled out a few yards above the surface of the planet's main ocean when she found a narrow gorge with dense vegetation that should fit their shuttle. She plotted a course that would lead them over rougher terrain to make them harder to detect with sensors and sent it to the General. “This is our destination, sir.”

“Good work, Carter!” He flashed her a quick smile as the shuttle shifted and adjusted its heading.

She nodded, hiding her own smile, and went back to helping the others keep the shuttle's system working. It wasn’t looking good. Whatever backlash that experiment had created had overwhelmed their shields, and even hardened systems had suffered. She ran a quick calculation. It wouldn't have affected a frigate or other capital ship, even the Flower II classes entering the Royal Navy would be fine, mostly, but it would wreak havoc on any smaller craft, such as shuttles and fighters. And destroy spy bots.

She checked the network. Yes, most of the bots near the planet had been destroyed or rendered inoperational.

“The stealth system is not going to hold for much longer!” Bow called out from the aft. “Its power supply is fluctuating. I'm manually compensating, but I can't keep that up forever!”

“I'm switching the system to the main power. It'll slow us down some, but the fluctuations will stop,” Sam retorted. They were still too far from the target area to lose their stealth. Rerouting the connections didn't take long. “Switching in three… two… one!”

Done.

“The fluctuations stopped. Stealth field holding.”

But it was weakening anyway - the projectors had to be damaged. It could be just some misalignments from vibrations, but the power fluctuations likely had done more serious damage. Sam would have to check later. And think of a way to harden the

systems further. A lot of missions would be affected if they couldn't trust the stealth shuttles.

“Alright, folks!” the General called out. “It's not going to be the Beggar's Canyon, but it's going to be close enough, so hold on tight!”

“What do you mean, ‘close enough’?” Glimmer asked just as the shuttle sped up again - and entered a narrow gorge for the last leg of their trip.

The General was a good pilot. Even though he spent most of his time on the ground, he requalified regularly. And ever since he had received his personal stealth shuttle, he had taken it out whenever he could find the time. He knew the shuttle probably better than most pilots.

Sam told herself that, repeatedly, but she still felt her stomach sink when she glanced out through the cockpit and saw the steep walls of the gorge loom far closer than she was comfortable with while the shuttle wove through tight turns with more speed than she thought was safe.

She had to trust the General. And even if they hit the walls, the shuttle was sturdy enough to survive a glancing contact. And the inertial compensators should let them survive a frontal collision as well, provided the General managed to slow down enough in time…

It doesn’t look as if he’s even trying, a small voice in the back of her head added as she looked away and focused back on her screen and data.

Minutes that felt like hours later, the noise from the engines changed - they were finally slowing down. Sam looked up again and saw that they were hovering, slowly gliding below a slight overhang, brushing aside dense foliage until they were above solid ground. Right on top of the marker she had set on the map.

“Welcome to yet another snake planet!” the General called out with a smile that almost managed to hide his own exhaustion.

“Switching off the stealth system and powering down,” Sam announced before she took a deep breath.

They had arrived. Now, they had to reach the base and deal with whatever was going on inside. Without being spotted by the guards. But at least they weren't depending on a failing shuttle any more.

*****

Near Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra glanced up, checking the sky - or the canopy of dense foliage, in this case - above them. “Sloppy,” she commented as she jumped over a fallen tree trunk, landing lightly on the soft soil behind it.

“What is sloppy?” Adora asked as she - with slightly less grace - jumped over the trunk as well, her boots leaving deep imprints next to Catra.

“This.” Catra motioned with her head at the trees around them. “In Apophis's place, I would have cleared the entire area of the jungle around their base. Clear the lines of fire and remove cover.” Sure, it would make it obvious where the hidden First Ones base was - unless it was a hidden Horde base - but Apophis had built a damn base above it, so that was no concern any more.

“Ah.” Adora looked around as well as their friends caught up.

“Are you having flashbacks to the Whispering Woods?” Glimmer asked while she struggled to get over the tree herself until Bow gave her a boost. “Ugh. We should restore magic to the planet.”

“Just so you can teleport past a tree?” Catra snorted.

“We're gonna save the magic light show for emergencies,” Jack said as he quickly climbed over it. “Like turning a dangerous snake or Ancient contraption into a potted plant before it destroys reality.”

As it had almost happened before. On her orders. Catra pressed her lips together.

“I'm not sure feeding so much magical power into a potential threat is a good idea,” Glimmer retorted. “We don't know how it would react. It might trigger the very effect we want to avoid.”

“Yes. We had to use magic to power the gate on Etheria!” Entrapta had no trouble having her hair carry her over the trunk. “It wouldn't have worked otherwise. On the other hand, without magic, it shouldn't be threatening reality as we know it. Probably.”

That wasn't very reassuring, in Catra's opinion.

“The Ancients were magitech users,” Sam added, climbing with the help of Entrapta's hair. “So, they might have left artefacts able to power whatever experiment they are doing with magic or similar energy.”

“If you tell me that we can't blow it up because it could absorb that power, too, I'm going to be annoyed,” Jack said.

“Wellllll…” Entrapta cocked her head and shrugged. “We don't know? We need more data!”

“Great,” Catra heard Jack mutter. “I'm not carrying all that C-4 back to the shuttle.”

“I’m sure we can find a use for it, Jack,” Daniel said.

Catra snorted and went ahead again. She had a base to sneak up to - they were halfway there, so they had to look out for patrols now. Their Naquadah-scanner might show every Jaffa and Goa'uld, and the odds of Apophis using humans on patrols were very low, but that didn't mean Catra could be sloppy.

Moving through the woods as if it was an obstacle course, jumping from trunk to trunk, her claws leaving gashes for the others to follow, she quickly put some distance between herself and the rest of their team.

The planet apparently had no birds or other flying animals, so she didn't have to worry about giving away her presence by disturbing a flock of those, but several small tree-dwelling animals scattered at her approach. She managed to grab one as she landed on a larger branch and quickly studied the squirming beast. It looked like a squirrel with longer claws. On Earth, no one would bat an eye except, perhaps, a biologist. It was nothing like the vermin she had seen in the Whispering Woods.

Probably a clue that this world hadn't been used for genetic engineering experiments, but Catra wasn't an expert.

She released the animal, waited until she spotted Adora catching up to her, then moved ahead again.

Half an hour later, she encountered the first sign of a patrol - tracks left in the dark soil. She didn't know how old they were, but Bow would be able to tell. But it meant they were now in the area the base guards patrolled.

Her ears twitched but caught nothing but her friends behind her.

Once more, she waited for them to catch up, then pointed the tracks out. Jack, Teal'c and Bow all knelt down to take a look.

“This was made by a guard wearing standard armour for Apophis's Jaffa,” Teal'c said.

“Four of them, a day ago,” Bow added.

“I'll take your word for it,” Jack said. “So, how often do they run their patrols? And how often do they vary their routes?”

“Warriors are supposed to take different routes each day and have one patrol out in every sector at all times, based on the size of the

garrison," Teal'c said.

Catra could hear the 'and woe to anyone who failed his false god' added without it spoken aloud. Teal'c had probably punished more than a few in his time as Apophis's Prime. "But this is a safe world, unknown to anyone, they have a fleet in the system and two Ha'taks in orbit. What are the odds they feel safe enough to get sloppy while slogging through the jungle?"

"I doubt Apophis will send any but his best, most loyal troops to guard his queen," Teal'c replied.

"For several reasons, not least because he wants them to guard him against betrayal by her," Jakar added. "But even so, in my experience, even the best troops tend to follow the same routes."

Catra shrugged. "I'll hear them before they spot us. Let's go."

She did spot a patrol on the last leg of the trip, but it was easy to keep out of their way - the Jaffa were limited to their eyes and ears, and those were not nearly as good as hers. Catra watched them from a hiding spot in the canopy while her friends hid a bit away. The Jaffa did look smart, all clean and tall, but they also looked a bit… tense. Not as tense as Horde scouts in the Whispering Woods, but those were warriors on a routine patrol where they didn't expect any trouble. Something had them on edge.

But Catra couldn't think of what that might be - there were no monsters in this jungle. At least none that she could spot.

*****

Jack O'Neill couldn't help grinning while he studied the base in front of him through his binoculars. How he had missed sneaking up on a snake base, hiding under their very noses while plotting to blow it up! He had been behind a desk for far too long!

He inched forward a little more, a number of the thorns of the bush he was using as cover snagging on his fatigues, and used

the button on the side of the binoculars to zoom in. Built with some fancy tech by Carter and Entrapta as a prototype, the binoculars allowed him to zoom in to almost magnifying glass level and switch between different vision modes, including thermal and low-light. And they were working great - he would have to light a fire under procurement's butts so they approved it for manufacturing at once. His troops needed this!

But that could wait. The mission came first. He studied the base. Massive walls that looked like they were taken from the set of Cleopatra, Jaffa in heavy armour patrolling on top of them between staff cannons mounted for air and ground defence, Death Gliders waiting on the pads inside… pretty standard snake stuff, except for the palace in the centre.

He zoomed in on it. It was a blocky structure, looking more like a bunker someone had gilded than an actual palace, rising higher than the walls around it. It was prime bombardment bait. But it also had balconies built into the front wall, and the top was covered by a pavilion, including a pool and lounge area. "Talk about lipstick on a pig…" he muttered.

He heard a snort from his left, where Catra was studying the base as well. "It makes Horde construction look fancy," she said.

Daniel would say something about different cultures having different styles and aesthetics, but Jack nodded. "I bet some billionaires without taste would love that style." And would probably add more gold to it.

Catra snorted again. "Good defences, though. And it's sitting right on top of the First Ones base."

As they had expected - the snakes preferred to keep tight control over crucial assets. Jack flipped through a few modes on his binocs until he reached the one he wanted. "Ah! There's the big reactor!"

"We already knew that from the orbital scans," Catra commented.

“But now we know where it's relative to the rest,” Jack shot back. “And we can see the shield projectors. Now, if I were a ring transporter, where would I be?”

“You? In the living room so you didn’t have to move to get a beer from the fridge,” Catra said. “But a snake's transporter?”

“Taweret would want it close to her personal quarters but not inside them. She would not tolerate others walking through her rooms every time they needed to enter the base beneath.” Jakar the snake commando cut in. “And her quarters will be near the top. She will want private access to the roof.”

There spoke the snake expert. Though Jack had come to the same conclusions. Placing your quarters underground would be safer, but that wouldn't allow the snakes to look down on everyone else. He zoomed in on the roof. “Yeah, there it is - door in that fake tent on the side. I bet if we wait long enough, we would see her making a big entrance there.” A bit far for a sniper, but Jack was sure he could do it. Not that he would - the odds of hitting the actual snake were slim, and killing the host wouldn't do anything but warn them of their presence while they possessed the next spare host. But it was a nice thought to have.

“You want to enter through the roof?” Catra asked.

If the stealth shuttle still worked, that would be ideal. Fly in, hover above the roof and drop down. “Unless Adora restores magic and Glimmer teleports us there, Or Carter and Entrapta somehow find a way to get the spare parts they need to repair the stealth system, I think we'll have to pick the side entrance,” Jack replied.

And that meant getting through the gate - or over the walls.

“I guess we can't ambush a patrol and take their armour,” Catra joked.

“Nope.” There were few slaves around, Jack noted. The base didn't look old - he could see signs of recent construction, actually - and it must have been built quickly, meaning with lots of hands,

so where were the workers responsible? Jack pressed his lips together. Apophis wouldn't move the workers constructing his secret base back to his other worlds. That would risk the base being revealed. So… What would a megalomaniac snake with no morals do to keep such a secret?

The answer was obvious and nauseating. Jack quickly scanned the area, but he didn't see any signs of mass graves. Or other possible disposal facilities.

And that was even more worrying.

“Let's look for blind spots and other weaknesses,” he said. Before they looked for unconventional solutions. Jack would prefer to do this without magic. If they had to restore magic, Adora would probably wipe out the Goa’uld base by accident anyway, and while that wasn't exactly a bad thing, it would also alert the Ha'taks in orbit and the rest of the fleet - and the Ancient base deep underground.

No, they needed a more subtle way inside.

Fortunately, Jack thought as he zoomed in on a small ditch near the base of the walls, I might have found our way inside.

*****

“You want to sneak in through the sewers?”

Adora winced at Glimmer’s comment. They were out of earshot - Apophis’s Jaffa had cleared a lot of the area around their base - but they were trying to stay hidden.

“It’s not actually a sewer,” Jack replied. “More like… a stream flowing out of their base.”

“It’s still a sewer - it carries all their waste away!” Glimmer retorted.

“And it is fed from a spring inside their base,” Sam added. “There’s no stream entering the base.”

So much for using a clean body of water to sneak in, Adora thought.

“Can’t be worse than infiltrating the Fright Zone,” Catra said. “Or sneaking around there.”

Glimmer glared at her. “We didn’t sneak through the sewers when we did that!”

“We did, actually. When we went to rescue you and Bow,” Adora corrected her.

“You didn’t actually *swim* through the sewers!” Glimmer shot back with a glare.

“You couldn’t have - some of the sewers there were so toxic, you needed protective gear,” Entrapta said. “That’s why the standard Horde uniform included a fully enclosed helmet.”

Adora nodded. “And uniforms were resistant to environmental dangers.”

“Is that why you’re still wearing your old uniform?” Jakar asked.

“Ah…” Adora smiled at him, feeling a bit embarrassed. She didn’t actually need that kind of protection as She-Ra. “They’re also very durable and comfortable!”

“If you match the general body type they’re made for,” Catra added. “I always had to customise my uniforms.”

It had been more a want than a need, as Adora remembered it, but that wasn’t important right now. “So, infiltrating through the stream.”

“Open Sewer,” Glimmer said. “Perfuma would loath this.”

“Anyone with a bit of common sense would loathe it.” Catra snorted. “That’s a disease outbreak waiting to happen.”

“And you want to swim through it to get into the base?” Glimmer asked Jack.

“Well…” Jack shrugged. “We’ve got these fancy new fatigues, with masks that double as diving masks…”

“Not all of us have those,” Glimmer said.

Adora wouldn’t have any problems thanks to She-Ra’s armour, but the others… Not everyone had the new fatigues, and even there, the masks wouldn’t cover more than their faces. They were meant to be worn with a hood for full NBC protection.

“You’ll survive,” Catra commented.

Adora glanced at her lover. Catra’s feet, hair, ears and tail would be exposed. And she knew that.

“It’s not going to be worse than sneaking around in the seedier parts of the Fright Zone as cadets,” Catra said with a snort.

Glimmer glared at her before scoffing. “Let’s go then.”

“Alright. We’ll have to deal with sensors in the stream and the grate at the wall,” Jack said.

“We can handle that!” Entrapta beamed. “We can hack the sensors - if they have any that resisted the effects of their experiments - and bypass the alerts when we cut through the grate. As long as we’re not seen.”

“Fortunately, the water’s muddy,” Jack said. “And we’re going in at night.”

“Muddy? More like shitty,” Catra commented with another snort.

Adora didn’t think it was funny, but Jack laughed at it.

*****

The stream was shitty. Adora didn't want to take a closer look at what exactly floated on the surface as she approached the stream and watched the bot Entrapta, Sam and Bow had rigged up disappear in it. Peeking over Bow's shoulder, she could see the feed from the bot - or the sanitised overlay from its sensors depicting the stream's bed as it started moving upstream.

"Alright… now… where are the sensors?" Entrapta mumbled as she stared at her own tool.

"It doesn't seem that there are any," Sam said.

"So, they cannot protect their own sensors from their own experiments?" Jack shook his head. "I don't think Apophis will accept that."

"I concur," Jakar said. "Though that won't keep him from deploying a new weapon system if he deems it effective enough."

"We'll stop him before it comes to that," Adora said.

"We've reached the wall - well, under the wall," Bow reported. "Doesn't look like there are sensors either."

"But the grate itself is powered - a low current, but if it's cut, that will be noticed," Sam added. "Scanning the array."

"We need to cut here to reach the control module."

"Yes. But that's hardened material. We should access it from the side."

"Yes! Like that!"

"Drilling."

"Oh, look at that - it's a simple but working design! Tiny crystals!"

"Easy to circumvent, though. Just let me run a few calculations on my tablet… Yes. We'll need two of the thicker wires, and about… this long."

"Yes, I concur with Bow."

"Me too!"

It didn't take the three more than a few minutes to bypass what security there was and fix the cable the bot had trailed to the grate. And then it was time for them to start swimming. In the 'muddy' stream.

Just dive down and try not to think about it, Adora told herself, trying not to grimace. This was important. She had to do this. She was She-Ra.

She took a deep breath, grabbed the cable the bot had laid, and entered the stream. As soon as she was completely underwater, she started pulling herself forward, following the cable to the grate.

Five minutes later, she reached the grate. "I'm there!" she said through her communicator.

"Good! Cut the grate along the sides we marked!" Bow told her.

She summoned her sword and did so. "Done."

"No alert. We should be safe to follow you then." Catra said.

"OK."

Adora just had to wait for her friends now. And try not to think about what kind of stuff was floating in the stream.

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Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

While their small infiltrator bot went ahead to explore the rest of the base and they waited in the stream, Samantha Carter made a mental note to build a prototype uniform that doubled as a drysuit with full-body protection as soon as she found the time. The odds of it getting approved were zero - the cost alone doomed any such proposal; the new spacesuits had been a struggle to get through procurement even though the need for such suits was obvious - but Sam would be able to use the prototype herself next time she had to swim through a sewer.

She shuddered and suppressed the urge to run her gloved hands through her hair. Focus on the mission, she told herself. This was just like having to crawl through mud in basic. Only worse.

The spy bot was circling the central bunker - or bunker/palace, as the General called it - and Sam was, hidden by the thick wall above them, watching its feed to mark potential entry points. Main entrance - too big to open without anyone noticing even if the squad of Jaffa guarding it were dealt with. Goa'uld megalomania working for them this time. Side entrance - small, heavily armoured, likely an air lock. And two guards in front of it. Second side trnance, other side… That one was a bit larger, with tracks of heavy machinery left on the ground in front of it. Still guarded, though. The roof was a possibility. But scrambling up the walls would leave them exposed to any guard watching from the perimeter or yard. There were gaps in the coverage by the patrols - she had analysed the pattern already - but they were not long enough to allow the group to reach the roof in time.

That left the balconies. Without sensors on them, they would provide cover and concealment while they dealt with the doors, and they were close enough to the ground to be reached quickly. Adora could probably throw people up to speed things up, and Entrapta's hair, while not long enough to reach the balcony from the ground, would further facilitate this.

Entering the private quarters of Taweret was a problem in itself, but securing or neutralising her was a mission objective, so they would have to deal with her anyway at some point, even if the

Ancient base was more important. If the best way inside was through her?

Well, Sam had no problem with that. And there was the possibility that, Goa'ulds being Goa'ulds, they could access the ring transporter from her quarters, or close enough, to achieve the primary objective of the mission as well.

The final decision was Adora's - and the General's - of course, but Sam was sure they would agree with her reasoning when she motioned and held her screen out to the others to check.

She wasn't wrong. A few minutes later, with the spy bot tracking the guards, they rushed to the wall below the balcony, Adora in the lead. A running jump took her to the top of the balcony, trailing lines behind her. Lines Sam and the others attached to the harnesses built into their fatigues. Or just held onto, in some cases.

"Everyone ready?" The General asked in a whisper through their communicators. "Go!"

And the line went taut, then dragged Sam upwards as Adora heaved. Sam barely had the time to get her feet against the wall and push off before she was pulled over the railing and rolled over the balcony's floor. Entrapta had an even worse time - Sam's friend would have hit the floor head-on if not for her hair, legs twitching for a moment before she managed to straighten herself. She was smiling widely, though, and already reaching for her tool when Teal'c, the last of their group, smoothly slid over the railing.

"Clear!" the General announced.

"Working on the door," Sam replied.

"No sensors here either," Bow whispered.

But the door was armoured. They would have to work to crack the locks. At least it was an automatic door. If the Goa'uld had

skipped any servos and just relied on servants to pull it open, this would take far longer.

As it was, thanks to Jakar's help - the agent had the most experience with the electronic locks on such doors - they cracked it in less than five minutes.

The quarters behind it were as luxurious as Sam expected. Not quite an exact copy of Amaunet's quarters on Saqqara, but they came close enough.

They quickly spread out through them, covering all rooms. There were no guards, and they found only two servants working in a side room. Teal'c and Catra stunned them before they could react.

And no Taweret.

"Aren't queens supposed to laze around and have grapes fed to them in their rooms?" the General asked.

"If she's not here, she's either somewhere else in the bunker - or in the base below us," Jakar stated the obvious. "We would have noticed her guard detachment moving outside."

"Unless she's in a ship," Teal'c objected.

Jakar inclined his head. "True."

"Well, wherever she is, we need to get a move on," the General said. "Where's the ring transporter?"

"Outside the quarters!" Entrapta announced. "Well, that's where our scanner shows an amount of processed Naquadah that matches the amount used in a transporter."

The General nodded. "Good enough for me. Let's go. We have a base to take over. Or blow up. Whatever it takes."

Catra was already moving towards the exit.

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The Secret Base Part 2

Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra stopped and cocked her head at the door, but she couldn't hear anything from the area outside Taweret's quarters.

"Anything?" Adora asked.

Catra shook her head. "She's got good insulation. Probably paranoid about spies overhearing her," she said. "Any cameras you can access?" she added, looking at Entrapta, Sam and Bow.

"Nothing," Entrapta replied. "The electronics they use here are pretty simple."

"Anything more complex probably does not survive the experiments," Sam said.

Right. This feels like infiltrating a Princess Alliance stronghold, Catra thought. Just without the magic defences. "So… we just open the door then and deal with whatever guards are placed outside?" She flexed her claws in case anyone had any doubts about what she meant.

"There will be guards outside," Sha're said. "And they will be familiar with Taweret's servants. We can't fool them with a disguise, either."

"Yes," Jakar agreed. "I fear subtlety won't help us here."

"Then blunt measures will." Jack grinned. "That's more my style, anyway. But we should try not to alert the entire base."

Catra looked at Adora, then flashed her fangs and nodded. "No problem."

They positioned themselves, Jack and Bow behind them, zat ready respectively arrow notched, and waited for Sha’re to operate the door. The servos whined - Entrapta mumbled that they were just a tiny bit underpowered - and the door started to slide open.

Catra dashed forward as soon as the gap was wide enough, then jumped to the side, vaulting over the guard to the left of the door. She twisted in the air, head pointed down, and lashed out, slicing into the man’s throat with her claws, and whatever he had been about to scream turned into a wet gurgle as blood shot out of his mouth.

On the other side, Adora tackled the guard into the wall, knocking the breath out of him, then smashed his head into the floor, helmet still on.

Catra landed on the floor, legs bending, gathering power to pounce - but an arrow hit the third guard, glue covering his entire head, and he stumbled, trying to rip it off, only for his hands to get stuck. A moment later, he dropped, shot with a zat - like the fourth guard.

“Clear,” Jack whispered.

Catra nodded and moved ahead, jumping over the growing pool of blood around her target. Her ears twitched, but she didn’t hear any alerts going off or anyone moving nearby. That was… suspicious. Shouldn’t the ring transporter be guarded as well if it was nearby? She reached the corner and stopped, crouching low on all fours to peek around it.

There was a door, armoured, but she couldn’t see any guards. Was Apophis trying to hide it in plain sight? She moved past it to check the next corridor but found no guards there either - though she could hear a patrol below her.

The others had reached the door in the meantime, so Catra doubled back. “Careful,” she hissed. “There should be guards here. And if they aren’t outside…”

"...then they are inside," Jack finished.

"Peekablue would be very useful right now," Glimmer commented. "But we can't linger. Let's go in before we draw more attention. We can take out any guards inside."

Probably. Catra still had her suspicions.

But Jakar was already cracking the lock, so she moved to get ready for another charge.

When he stepped back and to the side and she heard the servos starting to work, she tensed, ducking low so the others would be able to shoot over her head. Almost… now!

She launched herself forward, landing on all fours, claws digging into the floor as she whirled, ready to launch herself at… nobody? She sniffed. The air had a touch of… locker room smell?

Before she could narrow it down, the others rushed in, weapons aimed, and came to a stop as well. The room was, but for the controls for a ring transporter, empty.

"Well…" Jack shrugged. "I guess even we get a break sometimes. Unless it's a trap. It's probably a trap."

"Scanning!" Entrapta announced. "I don't detect any explosives. Or poison. Or anything else."

"The controls are secured with a code, but I can crack it," Jakar announced. "It's not very sophisticated."

Catra expected that. Any security measures on stuff you used every day had to be easy to use, or half the troops would end up skipping them just for convenience.

"And done… It's set to automatically pick one pre-programmed location," Jakar said.

“Alright. First wave: Me, Adora, Catra, Glimmer and Bow,” Jack said. “The rest of you come down once we give the clear.”

That sounded reasonable to Catra, and she stepped into the transport area. The others followed. Sam looked as if she wanted to argue, but she held her tongue.

“Beam us down, Scotty!” Jack said.

Catra snorted, and Jakar nodded. A moment later, the transporter started. Rings rose around them, and Catra felt a tingling sensation while her surroundings faded away.

And then she had to suppress a sudden urge to retch. It *stank*. Worse than a cadet barracks a month without any inspection. Glancing around, she saw the source - they were in a large room packed with people. People who shied away from them. People dressed in rags.

“I guess that’s where the slaves disappeared to,” Jack muttered next to her. “Should have taken Daniel with us.”

“Yes,” Adora agreed. She smiled at the slaves, but they looked even more scared. “Let’s call the others and…”

A rumbling noise, quickly replaced by a whining sound that kept growing stronger, drowned her out. Then, the entire room trembled, and Catra’s ears were assaulted by shrieks of panic. She clenched her teeth and slapped her hands over her ears, hissing with pain. What the…

It stopped as soon as it had started. Replaced by a buzzing in her ears - no, near her ears.

Her communicator had frizzed out.

“My tablet!” Bow complained. “They must have run an experiment!”

Hell! Catra bared her teeth. That meant half their gear - if they were lucky - just got fried.

"Carter? Carter?" she heard Jack snap.

No answer.

They had lost contact with the rest of their group.

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Holding Area, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill stopped trying to use his communicator. It was obviously broken. As were all the communicators on them. It wasn't a catastrophe, though - they might have lost contact with half the team, but Carter and the others were at the ring transporter controls. They could just get them out again. And would as soon as they figured out that their comms had been wrecked. Which would take Carter about a fraction of a second.

Actually, she should have already used the transporter to get them out again. She would have tried to contact them after they had arrived - certainly after the experiment went off. That meant…
"What are the chances this wrecked the transporter?" he asked.

"Uh…" Bow sounded evasive. That was a bad sign. "I don't think it would be destroyed. They wouldn't risk that, I think, would they?"

"I don't think they would keep doing those experiments if they wrecked their transporters every time," Catra said.

Jack agreed with that. But why hadn't the others transported them back yet? Had something happened to them?

"They're afraid of us," Adora whispered.

Right. They were surrounded by slaves. Jack looked around. The people were trying to put as much distance between them and Jack and his friends as possible - pressing themselves against the

walls in some cases. At least there were no kids here - just adults. No older people, either. Yes, those were the missing workers. And they looked maltreated - gaunt in most cases. Starved.

“You don’t need to be afraid of us!” Adora spoke up before Jack could think of the best way to handle this. “We’re here to help you!” She smiled at them.

But the slaves just cringed and looked even more afraid.

That didn’t deter her. “We’re here to save you!” she went on.

Jack suppressed a groan. They had to find a way to save themselves first.

“I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. These are my friends: Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon, General Jack O’Neill of the Tau’ri, and Bow and Catra. We’ve been fighting the Goa’uld.”

Jack winced. That could backfire - had backfired in the past. Some of the snakes’ slaves took their religion seriously.

But there were gasps.

“She-Ra? The goddess?”

Adora winced at that. But before she could deny that, Jack whispered: “Don’t deny it. They need to trust us.” If they suddenly swarmed them…

One of the slaves - a young woman - slowly approached, almost crawling on her knees. “We’ve felt your blessing, goddess! You healed us!”

And speaking of healing… She had a barely healed wound on her leg, Jack saw.

“Please help us!” A middle-aged man added. He was cradling his left arm.

"We will," Adora said. " Ah… you don't need to kneel. We'll get you all out of here."

"As soon as our friends get the transporter working," Catra muttered under her breath.

"I still can't reach them," Bow said. "And my tablet is…" he trailed off with a grimace.

Broken beyond fixing, then. Jack nodded. Most of the slaves still looked afraid. Or knelt. Or both.

"If needed, Adora can restore magic to the planet, and then I can teleport us back to the others," Glimmer whispered.

Jack nodded. And Adora could blast a way to the surface with all the magic.

"Uh, that might not be the best idea, guys," Bow whispered. "That experiment broke my tablet and our communicators."

"Yes?" Jack looked at him.

"It broke the magitech in both," Bow said. "I checked."

Jack frowned. That meant…

"But the magic hasn't been restored to the planet yet," Glimmer said.

"They're experimenting with magitech," Bow confirmed. "Must be First Ones technology."

"Like the portal in the Fright Zone," Catra whispered.

"But… magitech works well with or without magic on a planet," Adora said.

"Yes. Normal stuff. But these are dimensional experiments…" Bow bit his lower lip again. "We don't know what they'll do with magic available. If the First Ones built whatever the Goa'uld here use

with magic in mind, the experiments could have vastly different effects."

Jack grimaced. Things were already dicey enough without such a boost. "Let's save that for our Plan B."

"Yes." Adora nodded. "But we need to get those people out. We can't leave them here to suffer."

Jack looked around for a door or anything. They wouldn't just use a transporter to access this room, would they? Sure, it would improve security and make escaping all but impossible without outside help, but… None of the slaves were avoiding parts of the walls. They would, if they had ever seen such a door. "It looks like the snakes really limited access to the room to the ring transporter." Damn. Jack hated it when his enemies played it smart.

"Yes, they did," Catra agreed. She looked around as well. "But this doesn't look like First Ones style."

She was right! The walls were built in the same style, from the same material, as the base. "This was built by the snakes," Jack said. "And I don't think that they worked through the transporter for that." He didn't think they would have been able to start working in the middle of the solid rock and soil here. So… "They must have dug a tunnel from which they excavated the room," he said.

"And that might still be around - just sealed off!" Catra grinned and looked at the walls. "Time to check!"

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Adora clenched her teeth and tried not to show it; these people were looking to her to be saved, and she couldn't do anything for them. Some were even praying! And their expressions… She didn't know what was worse, the fear or the hope.

She was such a fraud!

“Adora! Come here!” Catra called out, interrupting her thoughts. Her lover was standing at a wall, waving, while the poor people nearby were moving away - slowly, on the ground, as if they were afraid to stand.

Which they probably were. Adora clenched her teeth again and joined Catra. “What did you find?”

Catra grinned, flashing her fangs, and rapped her knuckles against the wall. “There's a hollow space behind this wall!” she announced with her ears twitching.

Oh. Adora couldn't hear anything like that, but she trusted Catra. “So Jack was right.“

“I knew it!” Jack grinned and walked over to them, followed by Bow and Glimmer. They caused more movement amongst the prisoners - some cringing away, others slowly following them, shy, scared smiles on their faces as if they didn't dare to hope.

Adora had the sudden urge to crush every Goa'uld here for doing this to them. She struggled not to show her anger, though - the prisoners would be scared even more.

“So, do your thing, holder of the holy drill!” Catra quipped.

But the prisoners around them gasped, repeating ‘holy drill’, and more started kneeling.

Adora shot her lover a glare. That was her fault!

Catra snorted in return, apparently unimpressed.

Sighing, Adora changed her sword into a pickaxe, prompting even more gasps and prayers. She ignored them and stepped up to the wall. Glancing around, she made sure everyone was far enough away so they wouldn't be in danger of being hit by fragments, then raised her pick and hit the wall. Hard.

The wall all but exploded in a cloud of dust, and she felt shards and pebbles hit her. She drew her weapon back and watched the dust settle, revealing a crater almost a foot thick.

Behind her, Catra whistled, Jack made a comment about anger management, and the prisoners' prayers increased in volume.

Sighing, Adora swung her pick a few more times, opening a hole to reveal a wide tunnel. Wide but rough, she noted.

"That doesn't look very structurally sound," Jack commented.

"No, it doesn't," Bow agreed, moving forward to peer into the tunnel. "Most of the support struts look haphazardly placed."

"Guess they weren't meant to last long," Catra said. She cocked her head, frowning. "I think I heard some crack from them."

"Maybe Adora opening the hole has put more pressure on them," Bow guessed. "Or the experiment - the tremors we felt might be building up tension in the rock."

"And they probably have been running a lot of them - this was the second in a day," Jack added. "Better hurry up and get us out of here."

"And them," Glimmer said, nodding at the room.

Of course. Adora nodded, then turned to face the prisoners. "Stay here. We'll open a way and then get you out."

"Yes, goddess!" a young woman said, bowing her head amongst whispers and murmurs.

Adora wanted to correct her, but this wasn't the time for that. Instead, she turned and looked at the ceiling. If she restored magic and used the power it granted her, she could blow a hole to the surface. Like she had done in the Eurondan bunker. But that would endanger everyone above them, and if the whole thing

collapsed… Better save that until they had no other option. She nodded, pressing her lips together. “Let's hurry!”

She stepped into the tunnel, but Catra dashed past her, leaving small tracks in the dust on the ground. Ahead of them, the tunnel turned, and Catra stopped at the corner, kneeling and touching the ground.

“It's wet,” she said, rubbing her fingers and looking back at them.

“That’s probably why they changed their heading,” Bow said. “If there's a water vein ahead, they could have flooded the tunnel if they had kept going straight ahead. They also treated the walls here with some sealant.” With an almost sheepish smile, he added: “My brother Dig is a miner.”

Ah. Adora nodded and eyed the walls of the tunnel there. Yes, she could see some sort of coating there - but some water was still seeping through. On the other hand, there was no pool on the ground. Maybe it evaporated? The tunnel was pretty warm.

Catra, meanwhile, was already moving around the corner. “Damn! They collapsed the tunnel!” she hissed.

Adora followed her. She was correct - debris, rocks mostly, filled the tunnel. They were trapped! She would have to use magic to get them out!

Catra moved forward, picking up a rock and looking at it. “Blast traces.”

Jack peered at it as well. “Yeah. Looks like from a staff weapon.” He glanced at the ceiling, then at the rocks ahead of them. “If they shot the ceiling to collapse it, and the rock ended up here, then the blockade can't be too large.”

Adora nodded. That made sense. “So, I could dig through it.”

“You might bring down the ceiling if you do it, though,” Bow pointed out. He glanced around. “We need to support the ceiling

before you start digging."

"With what?" Jack asked. "Adora can't keep it up if she's also supposed to dig."

Bow smiled. "We can build stone arches. Like for bridges. Adora can cut the pieces from the walls of the prison."

That sounded doable. Jack looked sceptical, but Adora was already headed back to the prison. She trusted her friend.

And they had to hurry. People depended on them. The prisoners. And their friends back in the base.

She wouldn't let them down.

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Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter resisted the urge to once again try to raise the General on the comm. The communicators were fried - she had checked herself. Crystals shattered by whatever exotic effect those multidimensional energy experiments caused. It was almost certainly a magical effect - based on magitech, of course, since there was no magic available to directly power the technology used - to affect the crystals like that, although it was theoretically possible that a wave interacting with the crystals on just the right frequency would have worked as well. Theoretically. But that wouldn't have affected the other crystals in their gear, which had also broken when the entire room shook.

Maybe Apophis had realised that they used magic and was working on a countermeasure to counter their magitech-based weapons and sensors? And not merely their magitech gear, she added silently as she looked at the controls of the ring transporter.

"The transporter is out of action," Jakar said, straightening from where he had been bent over the console. "According to the

readings, it’s ‘resetting’.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded emphatically, her hair fanned out, holding up panels from where she was looking at the interior components of the transporter. “The crystal matrices have been knocked out of sync. Resynchronising will take some time, but I didn't find any critical damage. Except for serious wear on many components, though that’s still within safe parameters. Just that they could really use some maintenance and replacements soon.”

“It seems that the multidimensional energy discharges are severely affecting their own technology as well,” Sam said. That wasn't a sign of a mature - or safe - technology.

“We knew that already from the way they avoid using sensors in the base,” Jakar said.

“We suspected. We still suspect - this is just more support for that hypothesis,” Entrapta told him with a grin. “But it looks sound. Although we still don't know what they are trying to do! We really need to sneak into the research base!”

We really need to contact the General and the others, Sam mentally corrected her friend. They were cut off, their only way back disabled - temporarily disabled. But they just had to wait, she reassured herself. As soon as the transporters finished resetting, they could get them back.

As long as the group stayed within the transporter area - the ring transporter swapped the entire area between the rings with the target area. But what were the odds of the others staying put? Sam clenched her teeth. After losing contact for too long, they would assume the worst and try to get back on their own. Probably fearing that Sam's group needed help. Any second those transporters took longer to reset increased the chance of their friends leaving the transport area. “We need to prepare a message in case they have left the area,” she said. If only they could repair their communicators - or their radios. Those hadn't survived either. They needed tougher, hardened comms. With

more redundancy. Keep backup systems turned off. That should render them more resistant to such attacks.

“Someone is coming,” Teal'c interrupted her thoughts.

“Guards?” Sha're asked, zat'nik'nel ready.

“I presume so.” Teal'c cocked his head. “Several walking in step.”

A squad, then. Sam clenched her teeth. They should hide - if they were discovered right now, the mission would fail. And they would be caught in the middle of a base, with half their group missing, including their strongest. But hiding would mean abandoning the others… She pressed her lips together. She hated it, but they had no choice. “We need to leave,” she whispered.

“But…” Entrapta started to say.

“Now!” Sha’re cut her off. “We cannot get caught.”

No one else argued. Jakar was already moving to the door where Teal'c stood. Sam could hear the steps herself as she joined them - still a bit away but closing in.

“This way.” Teal'c led them into a side corridor.

Sam let the others pass, then followed them. Right before she turned the corner, she caught a glimpse of a Jaffa patrol walking past the side corridor towards the transporter room.

That had been close. Too close.

She could hear them talking but couldn't make out the words.

“One is complaining about the smell,” Teal'c said in a whisper next to her.

Her eyes widened. The smell? They had cleaned up some, enough not to leave tracks on the floor, but… She felt herself blush, silly as it was.

“They blame it on the ‘prisoners’ - and someone not airing the room after the last transport,” Teal'c went on.

Oh? Sam blinked. That smell - the stench of the air that the transporter had brought back when she had sent the General's group down! After swimming in an open sewer, it hadn't seemed too bad, but the Jaffa had noticed. And if there was no transport scheduled…

“They might blame it on a lazy slave,” Jakar whispered.

Might. Or, if they were diligent, check the transporter logs. What were the odds for either? Should they take the guards out? Sam tensed.

Teal'c shifted next to her. “They said the transporter is now working again.”

Sam gasped. That soon? “We have to take them out and secure the transporter!” she hissed. And then save the others!

But she could hear the transporter activating on the way to the room, and when she entered, the last ring was just vanishing into the floor. There was no sign of the guards.

“It smells different,” Teal'c commented.

Then the Jaffa had chosen a different destination than the one the others had gone to. Well, that didn't matter - they still had the old destination in the memory banks of the transporter and could…

She blinked, drew a sharp breath and rushed over to the console. A quick check confirmed her fear: The memory banks had reset as well. They had lost the transporter's addresses!

Sam felt the sudden urge to shoot whoever was responsible for running these experiments under such conditions.

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Holding Area, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Bow's idea had worked out. Or was working out - Catra watched as Adora finished the last support arc under his direction. Glimmer, holding a flashlight to illuminate the entire operation, was beaming as if she had come up with the idea, of course, but that was to be expected.

Catra glanced back towards the holding area, where a few of the slaves were peeking in. From their spot, they couldn't see anyone except Catra since she was standing at the corner - the perfect place to keep an eye on them and her friends. Well, almost perfect place; the wall was a bit too wet to lean comfortably against.

Two of the slaves realised that she had seen them - they must have good eyes since Catra was quite a bit away from them and the tunnel didn't have lighting installed - and ducked out, but the woman who had greeted Adora first stayed, staring straight at Catra.

Catra grinned and waved, and the woman bowed her head. She didn't try to enter the tunnel, though, so she wasn't about to disobey Adora's orders. Good. They couldn't fight whatever guards were in the area ahead with a bunch of poor slaves behind them.

On the other side of the corner, everyone took a step back as Adora started on the last part of the mass of gravel and rocks blocking the tunnel. A few hits with her magic pick reduced the stuff to rubble, which she scooped up after changing her pick into a huge shovel and spread it along the tunnel's walls, leaving a narrow path in the middle free. Catra would have to tease her about being a magical construction worker later. Once they were out of this pit.

She moved forward before Adora had finished fully clearing the blockade, quickly climbing over the remaining rocks and squeezing through the narrow opening on top.

“Catra! We don't know what’s on the other side!” Adora complained.

“That's why I am going in,” Catra replied, looking around.

“It's not safe! It could collapse!”

Catra eyed the ceiling. It didn't look particularly unstable or stable, so that was good enough for her. And it was only a few yards to a door - Goa'uld style, she noted - in front of her.

It should be safe enough.

She slid down the rubble on this side and approached the door. It was covered in dust and apparently hadn't been opened since the roof had collapsed. She could see where whoever had closed it had pushed back more rubble and rocks that must have fallen into the area behind the door. That was a good sign - it meant this part hadn't been abandoned. And the walls next to the door looked different. Familiar. She had seen that kind of metal before.

Behind her, she heard magic metal strike rocks, followed by a familiar grunting noise, then some huffing. Adora must have cleared away the last of the big rocks blocking the way and was squeezing through as well.

“Catra!”

“Just doing some recon,” Catra told her with a grin before nodding at the door. “Look at the walls.”

Adora peered at the metal, her armour shining brightly enough so even her eyes could see it, and frowned. “First Ones architecture.”

“Yeah.” Catra nodded. “Looks like we're at the underground base.”

“Let's hope it's the right one!” Jack joined them, followed by Bow and Glimmer.

“Ring transporters don't have the range to reach other systems, and we didn't pick up any other potential bases in the system,” Bow pointed out.

Jack grumbled in return. “So, can you crack this, or do we have to use my universal door opener?”

“Uh…” Bow smiled weakly and glanced at the ceiling. “I think we better don't use explosives.” He moved to the lock. “I should be able to open this even without my tablet. It's pretty simple. Like the ones above.”

Catra frowned. “So simple, the dimensional effects didn't wreck it?”

“Probably, yes,” Bow replied, fiddling with the lock before he pulled off the dusty cover. “Yeah, definitely.”

“So, they installed this after the experiments started?” Glimmer asked.

“Or they just didn't want to waste a better lock on a door leading to a tunnel they would collapse anyway,” Jack suggested. He shrugged. “Whatever. Let's go through and see what we can do to ruin some snakes’ day.”

“And save their prisoners,” Adora added, nodding firmly.

“Right.”

“Let me check first if I can hear anything,” Catra said, leaning forward to brush the dust off the door before pressing her ear against it. “No, nothing.” Again, good insulation.

“Guess it’ll be a surprise, then,” Jack said.

Hopefully, for the snakes and not for us, Catra thought as Bow pulled out some more tools from his belt and started working on the lock.

A minute later, the door chimed and started sliding to the side - only to get stuck almost immediately. Catra heard the servos moving it whine as they strained.

"Ah… it looks like they blocked the door as well…" Bow said.

Adora scoffed and stepped forward. She grabbed both parts of the door, clenched her teeth and pulled.

Screeching, the metal bent as she tore it open, revealing a corridor behind it that looked very familiar indeed. First Ones style.

Catra cocked her head, listening. That noise would have alerted all guards in the vicinity. Though, depending on how big the base was, they might have gotten lucky and escaped notice.

Or not, she corrected herself when Adora stepped inside, and a figure appeared in front of her - no, a hologram. She scowled at the sight.

"Greetings, visitors. Please identify yourself," the hologram said in Light Hope's creepy voice.

"Ah, damn, here we go again," Jack muttered behind her.

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Jack O'Neill was a human. Not an alien. That he had some alien genes that made some broken-down robot think he was an alien didn't change that. He wasn't a witch, either, but that didn't apply here. He had known meeting another Ancient AI was a possibility, but he had hoped it wouldn't happen.

Adora, though, was smiling. "Hello! I am Adora - She-Ra. These are Catra, Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon, Bow, General O'Neill and Jakar/Mats."

The hologram bowed. "Greetings, Adora, General O'Neill. Welcome to Research Station Beta."

Jack sighed. Once again, the damn robot was ignoring everyone else but Adora and Jack. Wait… unlike Alpha, this bot hadn't told them that the station was at their disposal. "Who is in charge of the base?" he asked.

"That information is classified, General O'Neill."

Damn. Jack glanced at Adora, who was frowning. As were the others. Someone else had already taken over the base?

"There's a First One here?" Adora asked.

"That information is classified," the bot - presumably Beta - repeated itself.

"I'll take that as a yes," Jack said. "Whoever's in charge is working with the snakes," he said in a low voice.

Catra nodded and whispered: "Can't trust the bot."

Adora cleared her throat. "What about the prisoners in the room behind us?"

"Those are test subjects."

Test subjects? Jack clenched his teeth. So that was how Apophis was disposing of the slaves who knew too much!

"Test subjects?" Adora sounded livid.

"What experiments are they running here? More genetic engineering?" Catra asked.

The bot didn't react until Adora repeated the question: "What experiments are you running here?"

"That's classified as well."

"I don't think this is going to get any better," Jack said. "We should…"

“We want to talk to whoever is in charge,” Adora said, taking a step forward. “I assume you have already informed them of our arrival.”

“That is correct.”

“How long until the guard spider bots arrive?” Catra mumbled, looking around. Before Jack could say anything, her ears twitched, and she hissed: “Incoming!”

“Take cover!” Jack waved, falling back to the door.

Adora, of course, took a step forward, sword changing into a shield. “We haven’t attacked them,” she said.

The hologram tilted its head to the side. “I’m following my orders.”

“It’s Light Hope all over again!” Catra snarled, moving to the side as Bow and Glimmer fell back.

Jack could hear running steps now - several of them. He crouched down and aimed his gun down the corridor.

“This is not necessary. We just want to talk to whoever is in charge of the base!” Adora said, raising her voice. “We don’t want to fight you!”

The bot didn’t reply.

A few seconds later, the first rank of the Jaffa rushed around the corner, and Jack greeted them with a burst from his carbine that struck the leading Jaffa in the chest, punching through the armour.

The Jaffa went down while his comrade fired his staff weapon.

Adora caught the blast on her shield and charged. She crashed into the Jaffa in the lead, sending him flying back - and into the second rank, who was just getting over the fallen Jaffa. All went

down, and before they could get up again, Bow hit them with a glue arrow.

Then Catra landed next to them, claws slashing down. Blood flew, and she dropped to the floor a moment before a volley of blasts flew over her head. One blew a hole into the wall behind her, the others were caught by Adora.

Jack snapped off another burst but then had to hold his fire while Adora made short work of the rest of the Jaffa in close combat.

"I think we need to have a talk with the guy in charge about his hospitality," Jack said. A quite serious talk. Probably dead serious.

"Yes. And about their treatment of prisoners," Adora agreed, then turned and started running down the corridor.

As the rest of them followed her, Jack hoped she had an idea of where she was going.

He caught the bot's hologram fading out, smiling in that creepy way of hers, when he glanced over his shoulder to check their rear.

That rust bucket also needed a serious talking-to.

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

The centre of the base had to be somewhere ahead of them. And there would be its current commander. Adora was sure. Pretty sure. She knew the layout of the base from their scans - approximately, at least; First Ones technology made scans from a distance a bit tricky - and Research Station Alpha was built similarly.

It didn't matter that much, anyway. The base wasn't that big, and as long as they kept moving, they would reach the command

centre sooner or later. As she had been taught in cadet training, it was better to make a decision and act than do nothing.

She turned around the next corner, shield held in front of her - and caught a volley of staff blasts from a squad of Jaffa waiting in ambush on it. Clenching her teeth, Adora rushed them. They got off another, more ragged volley before she bowled them over.

Behind her, she heard a scream cut short, followed by a zat going off twice, and then Catra was at her side. “More incoming.” She nodded at the corridor to their right.

“How many Jaffa are down here?” Jack complained as he joined them.

“As many as Apophis thinks are needed to keep our mysterious First One in line,” Glimmer replied.

“Well, he's rapidly losing his safety margin,” Jack commented, crouching to aim down the corridor.

“They've stopped!” Catra hissed. Her tail swished behind her.

Adora sighed and moved forward. If the Jaffa didn't charge in screaming praise for Apophis, they would either prepare an ambush or throw grenades around the corner. Neither would help them. This was a senseless waste of lives, and once Adora met whoever was responsible for this…

She heard a staff weapon going off, and a Jaffa was thrown out of cover, crashing against the wall to her side - hit in the back, she realised.

More shots followed, and she ran forward, turning the corner - just in time to see one Jaffa smash the face of another with the butt of his staff weapon, sending the warrior reeling, before flipping the weapon and firing point-blank into the man's chestplate.

Most of the gore and blood splattered against her shield. A few shards of the Jaffa's armour bounced off her own as the victim collapsed - on top of another corpse on the ground.

Before she could say or do anything, the remaining Jaffa dropped to his knees.

"Goddess! Please spare me! I have rejected Apophis for your wisdom and mercy!"

What? Adora blinked.

"I have seen your fury and felt your blessings on Saqqara when you showed your might against Apophis!" the warrior continued with his face pressed against the floor - halfway into a pool of blood, she realised. "Please accept me in your service!"

"Ah…" Adora hesitated, then forced herself to smile at the man even if he couldn't see her. "What is your name, warrior?"

"Atak, Goddess!"

"Killed his own squad," Catra commented in a low voice behind her.

That was true. Could they trust him? Could this be a ploy? Adora didn't know. But if he was genuine… Would Apophis really try such a trap? After going to such lengths to hide his defeat? And would the Goa'uld think of such a plan when they didn't trust each other at all? She didn't think so.

She slowly nodded. "Welcome to the Alliance, Atak."

"Thank you, Goddess!" the Jaffa loudly said.

Adora heard Jack groan behind her but ignored him. "Stand up and face us, please."

"As you command, Goddess." Atak slowly rose, averting his eyes.

“I am She-Ra, Supreme Commander of the Alliance,” she told him, trying not to wince at the blood on his face. She could sort out that she wasn't a goddess later. “These are Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon, Bow, Catra and General Jack O'Neill.”

Atak bowed towards her friends. “Your chosen companions. I saw them fight at your side against Apophis.”

So, he must have been among the guards they fought on Saqqara. And she probably healed him afterwards, when she restored magic to the planet.

“Yep. Our little dust off with dear old Apophis. How is he doing, by the way? And what are his people doing here?” Jack asked.

“And who's in charge here?” Catra added.

“The Goddess Taweret has joined Apophis as his queen,” Atak replied. “She rules this world - and commands this base.” He bowed again. “Apophis bade us to obey her as we would obey him. I have rejected her as I rejected him.”

“Good,” Adora said. But Taweret was in command here? She was a Goa'uld, not a First One. That made no… She blinked again. “Does the base - Beta - answer to her?”

“That’s the blue glowing hologram,” Jack added. “Talks about orders a lot and is generally annoying.”

Atak nodded. “Yes, Goddess. The base answers to her.”

Catra cursed next to Adora, as did Jack.

Adora wanted to curse as well.

Taweret must have a host with the First One gene. Or a First One.

Things were far worse than she had thought.

*****

The Secret Base Part 3

Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter faced her situation in a calm and logical manner. They had lost the address of the transporter to which the General and the others had gone. And they had no means to reestablish communication with them. In addition to that, Sam's group was currently trying to avoid detection in a Goa'uld base manned with elite troops since, with the absence of Adora, they didn't have the means to fight their way out of the base, much less take it over. And the multidimensional energy experiments the Goa'uld were running on the planet had wrecked half their electronics and all their magitech gear, making it impossible to call for help from the fleet outside the system and severely hampering their ability to subvert the enemy systems. Those were the negatives.

On the positive side, between her and Entrapta, they should be able to come up with ways to compensate for their current technical difficulties. If their own gear and tools didn't work, they would appropriate the enemy's, which, presumably, would still work. Even though, Sam had to amend that thought, not perfectly, as the wiped memory of the ring transporter had illustrated. Further, they weren't completely helpless. Teal'c was one of the deadliest fighters Sam knew and, as importantly, intimately familiar with the enemy’s troops and tactics. Sha're had inside knowledge of the enemy's strategy and planning habits, and Daniel was not only an expert in Goa'uld history and culture but also a savant when it came to interacting with different and alien cultures. Although Sam wasn't quite sure yet how that would help them in their current predicament, she had been surprised by him before. Positively. And they were currently in the ring transporter room of the base, without guards to worry about.

All in all, their situation was far from the worst Sam had ever experienced. Critical, no doubt, but they weren't doomed. Of

course, as a member of SG-1, her standards were probably a bit skewed…

“Do we have any clues to find potential addresses in the memory banks?” she asked. Randomly trying addresses had been a staple at Stargate Command at the beginning, and even after they had acquired lists with the coordinates of gate systems, they had been looking for more systems - especially systems unknown to the Goa'uld, in the hope of finding allies against them. Which actually had worked out beyond their wildest hopes when they had stumbled upon Etheria’s Stargate. But that didn't work with ring transporters - the coordinates for those had to be much more precise than those for a Stargate, where you just had to ‘hit’ the stellar system, and the Stargate would do the rest. Which could cause problems by itself if there were more than one Stargate in a system, but… She focused on the problem at hand.

“No,” Entrapta replied. “The energy used by the transporter could narrow the potential destinations down, but we don't have enough data to correlate anything. We would need to observe a lot more uses. And compensate for the energy loss caused by the slight damage to the transporter. So…” She pouted. ”... it's not going to work well enough for this mission.”

“And we can't follow the smell,” Daniel said with a rueful smile.

Sam snorted, more to reward his attempt to replace the General's dark humour than because it had been a good joke. “Let's bug the transporter so we can record the next addresses,” she said.

“But didn't you lose most of your tools?” Daniel asked.

“Most but not all,” Sam replied.

“Yes!” Entrapta beamed. “And we're limited to very simple, sturdy systems. But if we make them tiny enough, and add a non-crystal or chip-based way to store data, it should work!”

“‘Non-crystal or chip based’ data storage?” Sha're asked.

“A tiny printer!” Entrapta was already bent over the open console controlling the ring transporter. “I saw an ad for a printer and bought one to check the mechanics. If we use thermal printing - well, the principle, it'll be more like branding - we should be able to rig something up to transcribe the addresses and coordinates the transporter uses!”

“Yes.” Sam smiled. It would be a challenge, but if they repurposed a soldering tool and constructed some sort of controls from composite metal that bent when heated, they could make this. They just had to…

“If I may make a suggestion,” Teal'c interrupted her thoughts. “Since the Jaffa working for the false gods have used the transporter after its memory was wiped, they must have known the address and entered it.”

Sam grimaced as she finished his suggestion. “And they will have that written down so it won't get erased when the transporter's memory bank suffers another wipe due to accumulated damage. We just have to find those notes and take them.”

“Indeed.” Teal'c inclined his head.

Sam tried not to feel stupid for missing the obvious solution to their main problem. At least the General wasn't here to tease her about it.

On the other hand, if the General were here, she wouldn't have had to come up with such a plan in the first place.

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Great. Just great. A Goa'uld with a First One as host. In full control of a First One research station, aided by a crazy bot. “That explains the stupid experiments,” Catra muttered. “But why haven't they released their guard bots yet? We've just been facing

Jaffa.” And they could handle the Jaffa in their sleep. Maybe even without Adora.

Adora looked at Atak, but the Jaffa defector shook his head, bowing deeply. “Forgive me, Goddess, but I do not know what Taweret is planning. I am merely a guard; I was never taken into her or Apophis's confidence. Not even before the defeat he suffered at your hands.”

Catra snorted. With two of Apophis's Prime going rogue, it made a lot of sense that Apophis wouldn't trust them, much less the rest of his guards.

Adora smiled at the Jaffa. “There is nothing to forgive. You did not offend me - in fact, I am proud that you rejected Apophis and Taweret. I don't expect you to know all their plans.”

But it would have made things easier if you did, Catra silently added.

“Thank you for your mercy, Goddess!” Atak bowed so quickly, drops of blood were sent flying from his face.

Catra leaned into Adora and whispered: “Maybe add some divine decree about washing your face?”

“Catra!” Adora shook her head. “But we need to find Taweret. Do you know where she is?”

Atak straightened immediately. “Yes, Goddess! In her command centre! I can lead you there!” he said, nodding.

He didn't move, though. What was he waiting for, a written invitation? Catra blinked. Damn - he *was* waiting for orders from his goddess! She glanced at Adora.

Her lover was nodding. “Please do so!”

“As you command, Goddess!” Atak turned and started marching back from where he had come.

“I can’t wait for him and Priest to meet,” Jack muttered. “They'll probably debate the proper titles of their goddess for days. Or have a schism over it.”

“Jack!” Adora hissed while Catra chuckled.

But she was already moving faster to catch up with Atak. He seemed genuine, but as the humans said, better safe than sorry. If this was a trap, then she wouldn't let him lead them into an ambush.

Though as loud as his steps were, he might lead them into an ambush anyway without wanting to. On the other hand, the Jaffa would expect them to sneak, so this might actually be quite cunning - if he had thought about it. She would have to ask him later.

They reached another T-junction. No guards here - but Atak stopped before leaving their corridor. “The command centre is to our right. It is heavily guarded.”

Catra cocked her head. She couldn't hear anything from that direction… Wait! That sounded like metal faintly creaking. Someone must be shifting in their armour.

Behind them, the others arrived. “Command centre to the right,” Catra whispered. “Probably guarded.”

“Goddess!” Atak bowed again.

“Let's take them down.” Adora was mad, Catra could tell.

But Catra also knew her lover could control herself. At least enough not to kill Taweret's host, who was, probably, innocent. Though if they were a First One, that was more of a maybe - Between the Heart of Etheria and Research Station Alpha, Catra had seen enough to know that the First Ones hadn't been nice people. Or good people. She-Ras were the exception, of course.

“Let's go!” Adora nodded, changed her sword into a shield, and stormed around the corner.

Catra was hot on her heels. She heard cries of surprise and alert a moment before the first staff weapons fired, clenching her teeth as the wall next to her exploded from a hit that had missed Adora's shield.

They never learn, she thought as Adora crashed into the Jaffa formation, sending them scattering. One spun away and crashed into the wall next to her from the impact. Catra quickly veered off, slashing her claws through his neck guard and kicking the staff weapon he was still holding away.

Another had managed to keep standing even though he had been pushed to the door at his back and was swinging his staff to aim at Adora. She simply moved her shield, and the explosion from his own shot took the idiot out.

It barely scratched the door, though - obviously, the First Ones had taken care to protect their command centres.

“Let me check if there's…”

But before Bow could finish, Adora had stepped up to the door, pushed the slumped-over body of the Jaffa aside and rammed her newly changed sword through the gap in the middle.

Yeah, she was mad. Using - and killing - slaves as ‘test subjects’ would do that to her, Catra knew.

But just when Adora was starting to twist her blade to open a gap in the door, Catra heard a humming, steadily increasing noise again, and the whole room started to tremble. “Another experiment!” she spat.

“But… there was none scheduled!” Atak blurted. “I heard no order to fetch more test subjects, either, since the alert.”

They were using the slaves for experiments when their base was under attack? Catra shook her head. That went beyond stupid! Even for Goa'uld. But maybe not for First Ones.

“We have to stop them!” Glimmer gasped.

“We will!” Adora spat as the sound grew louder and the vibrations stronger. With a guttural grunt, she leaned in, reached into the gap - and tore it open.

And Catra jumped on her head, then pushed off, to the side, into the room. There was a line of Jaffa firing at Adora and behind them a woman wearing more gold than fabric - Taweret!

Catra flashed her teeth as she twisted, touching the ground, launching herself at the Goa'uld, her claws digging into the ground. This was…

Everything turned white.

*****

“CATRA!”

Jack O’Neill was still blinking, trying not to get blinded by the sun that had suddenly lit up the room or hit by the staff weapons he heard firing when Adora's scream made his ears ring.

“CATRA!”

Jack heard heavy footsteps, followed by more shots and screaming. And screeching metal.

He should have expected this. Or something like it. Still blinking rapidly, he cursed himself as he followed Adora into the room - just in time to see her grab the last Jaffa standing and lift him over her head.

The snake - Taweret - shot her with a ribbon device, repeatedly, but Adora just snarled, then hurled the struggling Jaffa at the

Goa'uld with enough force to throw her several yards back, into and over a console.

“Where is Catra?” Glimmer asked next to him.

Jack glanced around. He saw a snake and a dozen Jaffa on the ground, dead or unconscious, several weird Ancient devices, but no cat woman.

“Where is CATRA?” Adora screamed. She strode forward, grabbed the dazed snake by the throat and lifted her up. “What did you do to her?”

“Adora!” Glimmer blurted out.

“What did you do to her?” Adora repeated herself, shaking the snake like a ragdoll.

“Adora!” Glimmer ran towards her. “Stop!”

Jack clenched his teeth. That was why you didn't date your fellow team members. Adora was losing it in the middle of their mission. “She can't answer if you choke her to death,” he said - and tried not to flinch when Adora turned her head and glared at him with an expression that made a shiver run down his spine.

This is Adora, he told himself. She won't turn on her friends even when mad with grief. Or so he hoped.

“Please, Adora. Jack's right,” Bow said.

“Don't kill her - you'd kill her host,” Glimmer added.

Adora froze for a moment, then drew a sharp breath and released the snake.

Taweret fell down to the floor, wheezing and coughing, collapsing to her knees. Before she could recover, Adora grabbed her arm and tore her ribbon device off, crushing it in the process.

The research heads back home won’t be happy about that, Jack thought. He pushed the thought away. He had to focus. “What did you do?” he asked.

Taweret didn't even look at him. She was staring at Adora, who was towering over her. “Who… who are you?” the snake asked, then coughed. “What are you?”

“This is Adora.”

Jack whirled, raising his gun to his shoulder. Beta’s hologram was floating there, smiling.

“She is the new commander of Research Station Beta,” the bot went on. “The station is at your disposal, Adora.”

“What?” Jack blurted out together with everyone else - even the snake.

“You are no longer in charge of this research station, Queen Taweret,” the bot said.

“Traitor!” the snake spat. “I am your commander! A First One! You said so!”

Beta’s smile didn't change. “Your mental state is in doubt. Adora is the obvious replacement.”

“I am your goddess!” Taweret screeched before starting to cough and holding her throat.

“What are your orders, Adora?” Beta asked.

“Ah…” Adora blinked. “What did she do to Catra?”

“The subject used the station's experimental dimensional gate projector in a misguided and fairly desperate attempt to trap you in another dimension. Predictably, it failed, but your friend was caught in its effect.” The bot lowered its head. “I attempted to

stop her, but I could not countermand her orders no matter how wrong. I am sorry.”

Jack narrowed his eyes. The bot tried to stop the snake? Yeah, right.

The others looked shocked, though.

“Catra's trapped in another dimension?” Adora gasped.

“Like…” Glimmer trailed off.

Jack winced. Yeah, that would hit a nerve.

Taweret tried to scramble away, but Adora grabbed her head before she could scoot more than a yard. “Where did you send Catra?”

The snake must have found her spine again since she spat at Adora. “You'll never find her! None of the slaves ever got back!”

For a moment, Adora looked like she would murder Taweret on the spot. But she shook her head and scoffed. “That's what you think.” Turning to Beta, she said: “How many Jaffa are still active in the research station?”

“Two squads of four each are securing the power generator and the dimensional gate projector, Adora,” the bot replied.

“We need to take them out. And we need to secure the entrances,” Jack said.

Atak nodded. “We can turn off the ring transporter we installed in the base, Goddess.”

“That would cut off our friends as well,” Bow said.

Jack pressed his lips together. What were Carter and the others doing, anyway? They should have gotten the transporter working by now.

Adora hesitated a moment, then nodded. “Let's secure the base and lock Taweret up somewhere. Then we'll find the others and take out all Goa’uld forces in the system.” She turned to Beta. “And then we'll get all our friends back. No matter the cost.”

Beta beamed. “Research Station Beta is at your disposal, Adora.”

Jack couldn't help thinking that she looked like a scientist who had just gotten an unlimited research grant from the government. And why was she ignoring him? It wasn't as if he was an alien, but she had addressed him as one before, like Alpha, hadn't she?

*****

“The research station is secure. The transporter has been deactivated.”

Adora nodded at Beta’s report. She had taken out the remaining Jaffa while Bow had disabled the ring transporter with Glimmer and Jack. The survivors were now secured in a ‘holding area’ Beta had opened. Taweret herself was locked in what Beta had called a ‘containment field’ - force fields like those the Horde had used in their cells, just without actual walls. They had stripped the Goa’uld of all jewellery beforehand, of course - Goa’uld liked to hide their weapons and tools as jewellery. Or they liked using their weapons and gear as decorations. It was hard to tell.

Adora glanced at the woman glaring at her from her ‘cell’ in the corner and sighed. She had almost killed - murdered - Taweret’s host. A victim of the Goa’uld - and a prisoner of war. Technically, at least. Adora shook her head at her own… lapse. She should have known better than that. She was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance. She would have to do better than that. Even after what the Goa’uld queen had done to Catra.

She clenched her teeth, struggling with the rage and desperation filling her. Catra was… *trapped* in another dimension. And it was all Adora’s fault - she should have expected a trap instead of rushing in.

But she would save her love. And everyone else that Taweret had used in her evil experiments. She would get Catra back! She had done it before, she would do it again!

But you haven't been able to save Angella, a small voice whispered in the back of her head. It sounded like Shadow Weaver.

She pushed the thought away. She couldn't dwell on that. Not now.

"We've disabled the transporter," Bow announced when he returned with the others. "Temporarily. I can easily turn it back on, but I can't do it by remote - not without my tablet."

Which had been damaged by the multi-dimensional experiments. Adora nodded. "That leaves the ring transporter in the holding area." Where the slaves were.

"That's where the others will head to," Jack said. "We can't disable that."

"They would have reached us already if they could," Glimmer said. "They must be unable to use the transporter."

Adora pressed her lips together and looked at Atak. "You said it usually takes a few minutes for the transporter to reset after an experiment."

"Yes, Goddess!" Atak bowed his head instead of nodding. "But it doesn't usually take this long."

"It might have been damaged by the experiments," Bow said. "If it gets reset by the effects, then it is affected. It could have accumulated minor stress damage with each experiment until something serious got broken."

If the transporter was damaged, Sam and Entrapta should be able to repair it. It might take them a bit of time, though, depending on how severe the damage was. That was the best case. "We

need to contact them. Can you control the ring transporters here?" she asked Bow.

"Once I crack Taweret's controller, yes," he replied. "But that will take a while."

"So, we'll disable the ring transporter in the holding area until you can control them," Adora said. "And evacuate the slaves to the station here." She turned to Beta's holographic projection, which was floating nearby. "Do we have sufficient quarters for them?"

Beta nodded. "Yes, although with limited comforts."

"What does that mean?" Jack asked.

"They will have to stay in crowded quarters with limited supplies."

"Is it better than their current, ah, quarters?" Adora asked.

"Yes."

Adora nodded. "Good. Prepare the rooms. We'll fetch them."

"As you wish, Adora." Beta faded away.

Adora turned to the others. Bow would have to come along to disable the transporter. And she wanted to keep Atak close to her. Just in case. But someone would have to stay here and both guard Taweret and the control room of the station."

"I'll keep an eye on the snake," Jack said with a wry, humourless smile.

He was the best choice - he had the Ancient gene. Although…
"Beta," Adora spoke up.

Beta's projection reappeared. "Yes, Adora?"

"Jack's in command until I return."

“I assumed that already, Adora.” Beta glanced at Jack. “But it is good to have confirmation about your chain of command.”

“He also outranks Taweret,” Adora added. “Actually, she has no authority over you.”

“I also assumed that.”

Jack frowned. “Speaking of Taweret, are you aware that the real Taweret is a parasite controlling a First One host and not a First One?”

“Yes.” Beta nodded.

“And you let her take over the station?” Adora blurted out. How could Beta have allowed this?

“I surrendered the station to the First One Zahra. She then voluntarily surrendered her body to Taweret,” Beta said. “Apparently, she considered that a great honour and ordered me to obey her religious figure as if she herself were giving the order. Since that order was given before she became a host and I lacked any other legitimate authority figure to countermand it, I was bound to obey her.”

That explained it. Zahra must have been a slave conditioned to worship Taweret.

“Just following orders, huh?” Jack commented.

“Yes.” Beta smiled. “That was what I was built for.”

Adora grimaced. On the one hand, she knew that blind obedience was a terrible idea for any organisation. Especially if the First Ones were involved. On the other hand, having the bot in control of a First Ones research station acting on their own wasn’t a good idea either. Not at all. And if Taweret’s host was a true believer in the Goa’uld’s divinity… Well, that could wait for a moment. They had to finish securing the station,

She nodded. “Let’s go. And once we’re back, you’ll tell us everything about those experiments.”

“Yes, Adora.”

*****

Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Alright! We’ve hacked the security system! As far as you can call it a security system, of course. It’s more like a bunch of sensors that all report to one central authority, though as far as we can tell, at least, the readings aren’t integrated there.”

“It’s probably just guards watching screens,” Samantha Carter summed up Entrapta’s explanation for the others.

“Yes. Their experiments must really handicap their security,” Entrapta agreed. “That’s why setting up a proper lab and testing grounds is so important!”

“Their loss is our gain,” Sha’re said.

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded slowly. “But it behoves us not to underestimate Apophis’s guards. They will be very alert - as soon as they suspect our presence, they will put the base on alert and mobilise all available warriors.”

“So, we best not get noticed.” Daniel smiled, but it looked a little forced.

Sam could understand that - they needed to either steal the coordinates the guards used from under their noses or ambush a patrol with them. Either was a challenge. Ambushing a patrol without alerting anyone might be easier, especially with the security sensors under their control, but sooner or later, the rest of the guards would notice the missing patrol and react accordingly. Sam would really prefer to avoid that until they had linked up back with the rest of their team.

She looked at the feed on the screen Entrapata and she had cobbled together - ‘sturdy enough’, according to her friend, to survive the next experiment. Unfortunately, the security centre wasn’t covered by the cameras. But the two corridors connecting to it were, and when the doors opened, parts of the interior were revealed.

And that didn’t look promising. Sam had spotted at least three guards inside. Probably more - the room was large, and a decent part of it was not visible from the cameras’ angles, even with the doors open.

“They might be keeping the guards ready at the security centre,” Teal’c said, “in order to direct them to any possible security breach at once without interference.” He looked at Sam. “Taking all of them out without raising an alarm might be difficult.”

And if Teal’c said that, it meant impossible - at least for the team they had available. Unless… “The security centre is supposed to be protected against gas attacks, right?” Sam asked.

“It’s a standard precaution,” Teal’c replied.

“Yes. Poison gas used to be a staple for assassinations and coups in the past until most System Lords adapted,” Sha’re agreed. “It hasn’t been used much lately, as far as I know.”

“That means they will have an internal oxygen supply,” Sam said. “But will they have adjusted that for the interference from the experiments?” The base was rather new, after all, and people tended to cut corners when rushing things. The security system showed that already.

“Oh!” Entrapta smiled. “But where do we get poison gas?”

“We don't,” Sam replied. Not technically, at least. Then she started to explain.

*****

Samantha Carter looked up at the ventilation duct's opening. Entrapta's hair was waving at her. So, everything was ready. Good. She checked her screen. She couldn't see any patrols in the area. And they couldn't wait any longer any more - the risk of being detected was too great. She tugged twice on the strand of hair and watched the screen again.

For a few seconds, nothing happened. Then the doors flew open and a dozen Jaffa rushed out of the centre, followed by a cloud of smoke before the doors closed again. An alert sounded in the base as well, and Sam tensed. That was the largest weakness of their plan. If the Jaffa were too stubborn or suspicious…

On the screen, she saw two patrols rushing towards the service centre. They were carrying firefighting gear. She smiled and took a deep breath - it seemed their plan was working. Now, if everything else worked out…

She pressed her lips together as the seconds passed. On the screen, the Jaffa gathered in front of both doors, extinguishers ready. Sam made a mental note to study the gear afterwards - this would also give them intel about the damage control skills of the enemy fleet.

Then the doors opened, and the guards, wearing full-face helmets, rushed in to fight a fire that had never been real. And as she had hoped, the Jaffa seemed to assume that the life support unit had simply broken down - at least they acted like that was the case; Sam was sure that if they suspected enemy action, they wouldn't stand around complaining.

“All done!” Entrapta's voice sounded above Sam's head. “The unit was easy to sabotage!”

She looked up and saw Entrapta wriggle out of the ventilation duct. Even a person as small as her friend had trouble fitting through them. Without her hair, she wouldn't have been able to move quickly enough through the ducts - or at all. But she had

managed. And now the Jaffa would be busy airing out and repairing their security centre.

"I got pictures off their sheets!" Entrapta announced as her hair tendrils set her down on the floor. "It felt like back in the Fright Zone! We should travel through ventilation ducts more often! It's efficient and fun!"

Sam smiled. "I'll take it under consideration. But let's head back to the ring transporter." And get the others back, she added to herself as they quickly moved along the planned route back to the others.

Her good mood vanished as soon as she tried to use the transporter, though.

The receiving transporters were not active.

*****

Unknown Location, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

When Catra finally could see more than blurry spots, she found herself floating and staring at nothing. "Adora?" she asked, turning around. Adora had been right behind her. And a bit to her left.

But Adora wasn't there. Her head swivelled frantically while she looked around and above and below. Nothing. Just white emptiness. She was floating in…

She drew a sharp breath when she realised what had happened. She had charged into a trap, foolishly thinking she had the drop on the enemy, and now… Was this the afterlife? Dying was supposed to hurt, though. On the other hand, if she had been killed so fast, she didn't realise it until now, would it have hurt?

But what would have killed her? Some disintegration ray? The Goa'uld had the technology, zat'nik'tels proved that, but they took three hits to completely dissolve your body. But they might have

improved on that - this was a research station. And they had used slaves as test subjects…

Her eyes widened. This wasn't a Goa'uld research station but a First Ones! And one dealing with multidimensional energy discharges or whatever Entrapta and Sam had called it. And she had heard the sound of another such experiment when they had breached the room, and so…

She closed her eyes and hissed through clenched teeth.

…she was probably in another dimension. Or dead. Couldn't exclude that.

Not that it mattered, Catra guessed. Not when she was stuck floating in nothing. At least it was bright and not dark. Being lost in total darkness would be worse. Much worse.

Not that she had much to look at - just herself.

She looked down at her body, wriggling her toes for a moment, unsheathing and sheathing her claws. She didn't feel dead. Or weird. She cocked her head, moved her ears and tail, stretched. Everything felt like it should.

And yet… She sniffed the air. She smelt her sweat, but only traces of smoke, dust and the stench from the slave area. But nothing else. This weird space where she was floating had no scent of its own. And no sound - her ears didn't hear anything.

Maybe she was dead, and this was the light you supposedly saw when dying. And the afterlife was an eternity floating in nothing.

She hissed again and forced the thought away. She wasn't dead. She was just… trapped in some dimension. The others would come for her. Adora wouldn't abandon her. She would do everything to get Catra back. They would have taken control of the research station now. Soon, they would bring in Entrapta and Sam. And call in Hordak - he had experience with dimensional travel.

No, it wouldn't be too long before Catra would be saved. She just had to be patient and wait. She could do that. Just do nothing. Enjoy the quiet. Relax. Rest.

She closed her eyes and took a deep breath. Still no scent. No sound other than her breathing. It was peaceful. And the temperature was fine. Not warm, but not cold either.

She stretched again and shifted around. It was like being out in space. Just without a spacesuit. But the lack of gravity was the same.

Still, it wasn't the best spot for a nap. She didn't need a bed, but a patch of sunlight would be nice. Floating in the sun, warm and comfortable… She sighed at the thought.

And felt her skin grow warmer.

She opened her eyes with a gasp. What the… There was a sun? She turned her head, then had to jerk away, closing her eyes. Yes, there was a sun. But how? Had she been moving all this time? Or had she travelled into another dimension? Or…

A soft sound made her ears twitch, and she turned. Another light, a bit away, not nearly as bright as the sun, had appeared - and was fading. Replaced by… a glowing person?

She squinted. The person was floating like Catra was - and turning around. As soon as they saw Catra, they flew straight at her.

Catra blinked. That was… Her eyes widened. That was… "Adora!" She had found her! Just as Catra had known she would.

Adora came to a stop in front of her. "There you are! Don't be afrai… Catra?"

"Adora!" Catra beamed at her. "You found me!" It was her. Although she was wearing her old outfit, Catra noticed. The one with the skirt and shorts.

And she was glaring at Catra with an expression that made her flinch.

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Carter and the others were still out of contact. Not *missing* - they were probably raising hell in Apophis's base on top. Just unable to contact them for technical reasons. Jack O'Neill was sure of that. Pretty sure.

Besides, if the Jaffa had fought the others, or even just detected them, they would have contacted her scaly majesty at once, and they hadn't received a call on the station's comm so far. Unlike the snake's comm, or the Etherians', the station's FTL comms had been 'specifically hardened to resist the experiments' side effects', as the bot had described it, and Taweret had had a set of those comms moved to the base on the surface. Unfortunately, it was in the security centre there, so the odds of Carter and the others being able to use it weren't great - and if they managed to get control of the comms, they wouldn't take the risk of trying to contact the underground station and alert Taweret.

It was really annoying that they had comms back and still couldn't reach the others. At least they had been able to use the station's FTL comms to reestablish contact with the task force outside the system.

"...so, stay ready to launch the prepared attack on our signal," Jack heard Adora order in the background.

"As you command, Your Divine Highness!"

"It is remarkable that you have been able to subvert our ancient enemies." The Bot's projection appeared next to Jack, almost startling him.

"They've seen the light," he replied with a twisted grin.

“The task force is ready to take out the Goa’uld forces in the system,” Adora announced, walking over to them. “Now, Beta, tell me everything about the experiments you were running here!”

“Yes, Adora.” Beta nodded. “As you are already aware, this station - and myself - were built to conduct multi-dimensional research. As you likely know, bridging alternate realities is possible, but travelling there is quite dangerous due to the entropic cascade effect. Because of this, this station was tasked with finding safer ways to reach alternate universes and came to build the Dimensional Gate Projector.”

“Yep, of course, entropic cascade stuff, we know everything about that.” Jack nodded, then glanced at the others. They seemed as lost as he felt.

“Good.” Apparently, the bot wasn’t programmed for sarcasm.

Wait! Jack blinked. “Are you talking about the Quantum Mirror?”

Beta cocked its head, looking confused. “I am not familiar with that designation.”

“That alien device that allows travelling to an alternate reality,” Jack said. “Daniel used it once and went to a universe where Earth had fallen to the Goa’uld. That was why he could warn us about Apophis’s attack. It kinda looks like a mirror. Sort of.” He made vague motions with his hands to show the outline.

“I am not familiar with such a device,” Beta said.

That was weird. Shouldn’t an Ancient bot know about that device?

“Where is it? This could significantly advance our research!” Beta had an almost eager expression.

Scratch that, Jack amended his thoughts as the bot leaned in, definitely eager. He had seen housewives looking more distant while pressed against Target doors on Black Friday.

"It was destroyed, actually," Bow said. "*Because* it's so dangerous. The energy needed to breach the dimensional barrier is so massive, a containment failure could have wrecked reality itself."

Beta glared at him. "That's not a reason to dismantle it! That's a reason not to fail an experiment!"

Jack couldn't help thinking that he wasn't really sad that the people who programmed this bot were gone.

"What's done is done," Adora cut in. "What exactly were you doing here? What did happen to Catra?"

"Your, ah, friend was targeted by a portal that was part of an experiment using unstable dimensions as a travel medium to reach alternate realities," Beta replied.

"Unstable dimensions?"

"Proto-pocket dimensions," Beta explained. "Generated but not yet completed. The theory is that they will be able to bridge alternate realities that are so close to ours, that the entropic cascade effect will not appear. Unfortunately, we haven't been able to verify this so far." The bot frowned. "But recently, Taweret had changed the parameters of the experiment. Instead of retrieving test subjects to refine the mechanics of safe dimensional travel, she wanted to focus on its use as a means to remove starships and other objects from our universe - even though this had already been demonstrated successfully during the war against Horde Prime."

Jack blinked. They wanted to weaponise this? Wait - the debris they had analysed earlier! "You've blown up Horde frigates?"

"Yes." Beta nodded. "Although it was an unsuccessful test for transporting starships, it worked as a weapon and removed a threat to this station."

Damn! Jack clenched his teeth. If they had attacked right away with the task force, they would've run straight into this…

“If it already worked as a weapon, why were you doing more experiments with it?” Glimmer asked.

“The power requirements and side effects of dimensional travel prevent its use as a ship-based system, especially when installed on a vessel using inferior technology such as a Ha’tak, though Taweret was determined to change this. So far, she hasn’t succeeded.” Beta sounded actually smug about this.

“The power transfer to the Ha’tak in orbit!” Bow exclaimed.

“Yes. The damage to the ship has been more limited than in her first attempt.”

First attempt? The missing Ha’tak! Taweret must have blown it up in an experiment. So, they didn’t have to worry about Ha’taks sending Horde frigates into other dimensions. And if Jack had anything to say about this, they would never have to.

“This ends now. Your only goal is to find Catra - and the others - and take them back!” Adora ordered.

“This will require more experiments, Adora. With test subjects as before.”

Beta sounded too eager again, in Jack’s opinion.

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The Secret Base Part 4

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We're not using people as test subjects!" Adora snapped at Beta.

The bot's projection frowned. "But how else do you suggest we develop the technology necessary to recover your friend? As I explained, since Queen Taweret had ordered the experiments' parameters changed, we have made no progress with the recovering part of the project."

"We'll find another way!" They had to! And they would! "We'll get Entrapta and Sam working on this. And Hordak."

"I am not familiar with any of these people," Beta replied.

"Smartest women in the galaxy," Jack commented. "Except for Hordak, of course."

Beta cocked her head sideways and looked at Jack. "If Hordak is not as smart, why would she be included in the research?"

"I meant he's not a woman," Jack explained.

"Ah."

"He has experience with transporting people into other dimensions," Adora said. That was how Hordak had arrived on Etheria while it had still been trapped in Despondos. Oh. "We'll also have to go through the databanks on Etheria that remained from Light Hope." She clenched her teeth at the thought of Light Hope's actions, Mara, and everything else that had gone so wrong.

"Light Hope? I am not…"

"...not familiar with that person, yes, yes," Jack cut in.

“She was a bot like you,” Adora explained. “She transported me from this dimension into Despondos when I was a baby.”

“Oh. Another like Alpha and myself?” Beta perked up. “And you have access to her data about dimensional travel?”

“We don’t know. She was destroyed during the war against Horde Prime,” Adora said. “But she wasn’t in control of a research station like you and Alpha are.”

“And yet she managed to transport people to and from other dimensions? We must recover as much of her data as possible! This could massively advance our research here!” Beta nodded eagerly. “And, of course, this could be crucial for recovering your friend.”

Yes, of course - Adora should have thought about this immediately! Mara had been able to transport the entire solar system of Etheria into Despondos! Adora should be able to recover Catra. Especially if she had the power from restoring magic to this world at her disposal.

But she didn’t know how to do it. She bit her lower lip. If she tried this and failed, wielding the power of a world’s magic, the consequences could be catastrophic.

Then I can’t fail, she thought, nodding again - before remembering what Beta had said about not failing experiments. Maybe…

“Adora?”

She blinked. “Yes, Glimmer?”

“You were kinda… zoned out.” Glimmer smiled a little weakly.

“Sorry!” Adora matched her smile. “I was… thinking about alternatives.” She shook her head. “First, we need to contact the others. And quickly.” Before something else went wrong.

“You could use the dimensional gate projector to deal with Taweret’s guards,” Beta suggested. “The coordinates of their base are known. And this would net us more data about dimensional travel, potentially facilitating your friend’s recovery.”

What? Send more people into another dimension? Even if they were working for Apophis, that would be cruel. Even if, once they could save Catra, they could save everyone, it would be…

“Our friends are also in that base,” Jack reminded her. “We don’t want to accidentally transport them into another dimension, do we?”

Right. Adora shook her head. “We’re not using the dimensional gate projector on anyone.”

“That will severely hinder our research into recovering your friend,” Beta said.

“We’ll manage,” Glimmer told her.

“Yes, we will.” Adora looked at the others. “If we can’t contact the others, then we’ll have to clear the base ourselves. The guards still haven’t tried to contact Taweret, so they haven’t been caught.”

“Using a transporter requires an active transporter as a destination,” Beta told them. “Otherwise, the energy used will be released in an uncontrolled and usually highly destructive manner.”

“We’re aware of that,” Jack said. “Don’t worry.”

His smile was a little too toothy. It reminded Adora of… She didn’t want to go there. “Let’s go,” she said. “Jack, stay here.”

He didn’t like that. Not at all - his expression told her that. She understood, of course; she wouldn’t want to stay back when they were going to save Catra. But he was the only other ‘First One’

here with them, and while Adora didn't think Beta would betray her, there was just something about the bot that made her wary.

And judging from the glance Jack sent at the bot before he nodded, he felt the same.

"Yeah, right, sure."

"Let's go!" Glimmer was already moving.

Two minutes later, they were at the ring transporter, and Bow was checking the controls.

"The transporter in the Goa'uld base is active," he reported.

Adora nodded and drew her sword. "Send me up first." She could handle staff weapon blasts from an ambush. The others couldn't. "Give me a minute to get clear before you follow." And to clear the room if necessary.

Glimmer frowned at her but didn't argue. Bow nodded, and Atak straightened. "Yes, Goddess!"

Then Bow pushed a button, and the rings rose around Adora. She took a deep breath and tensed. If this was a trap…

The world shifted, and she appeared in the base transport room - surrounded by her friends, all of them aiming their weapons at her.

"Uh… Hi! Sorry for being late!" She smiled at them.

*****

Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter lowered her weapon and nodded at Adora. And tried not to feel slightly annoyed at the fact that her plan to get

the coordinates for the transporter had just been rendered redundant. “What happened?”

“Adora! You’re back!” Entrapta. “How are the others? Did you find the base?”

“Yes, we did,” Adora replied. She lost her smile, though, Sam noticed. “We captured Taweret, dealt with her guards and secured the research station. But we lost Catra - Taweret used an experimental gate projector to transport her into another dimension, and we need to get her back!”

Sam drew a sharp breath. Lost in another dimension? The odds of Catra surviving that weren’t good. Not at all.

Entrapta gasped. “Like Angella?”

Sam winced. Glimmer’s mother had sacrificed herself to stabilise an interdimensional portal that had threatened to unravel reality.

“We don’t know. Not yet. Things are different,” Adora said as she left the transport area. “The others are fine. Ah! We also met Atak - he’s a former guard for Apophis who deserted them and joined us.” She winced. “He, ah, worships me.”

Sam glanced at Teal’c. That was his area of expertise. Well, Jaffa deserters, not the religious part.

“I see.” Teal’c slowly nodded. “He was on Saqarra then when we raided Apophi’s palace?”

“Yes!” Adora nodded, then checked her watch. “The others should arrive shortly.”

As if they had waited for a cue, the rings rose again, and the rest of Adora’s group appeared. Except for the General, though.

“Jack’s, ah, keeping an eye on Taweret and Beta, the bot controlling the station” Adora must have noticed Sam’s reaction.

“Like Alpha?” Daniel asked.

“A bit too much like her, yes,” Adora said, wincing. Then she straightened. “So! We’ve reestablished contact with the fleet. We can coordinate our attack on the base with the strike at Apophis’s ships in the system.”

“We’ve temporarily sabotaged their security centre,” Sam informed them. “But that won’t last.”

“We don’t need much time.” Adora checked her watch again. “We’ll take over the security centre; there should be a working FTL communicator there so we can contact Jack and the fleet and coordinate our attacks.” She looked at Atak. The Jaffa was staring at Teal’c. Both nodded after a second. “Teal’c and Atak take the lead. Once we have taken the security centre, Sam, Entrapta, Daniel and Sha’re guard it while we attack the rest of the base,” Adora went on. “Everyone got that?”

“Yes,” Sam said in unison with the others.

“Alright! Let’s go!”

They followed Teal’c and Atak out of the room and quickly reached the security centre from which some smoke was still escaping. Despite that distraction, one Jaffa noticed them. His alert was cut down by Teal’c shooting him with a staff weapon, but the rest of the guards whirled and grabbed weapons.

It didn’t do them any good, though - Adora charged ahead and smashed into them before they could form a line, continuing into the security centre.

Atak and Teal’c finished off the survivors before Sam could line up a shot. Adora had been more brutal than usual, Sam noticed as she stepped past the crushed and blown-up bodies. Sam did not doubt that Catra missing was the reason for that.

Inside the security centre, the smoke was on a nuisance level.

Adora finished the last guard as they entered and turned toward them. “Contact the fleet and Jack. Tell the fleet to initiate the attack so they strike in three minutes.”

Sam didn’t quite run, but she made sure to get to the comms first, then opened channels to the General and the Task Force.

She reminded her to stay professional when talking to the General and informed him of the plan before contacting the fleet.

Meanwhile, Entrapta had taken over the FTL scanners, and while Adora led the others out and Daniel and Sha’re stood guard at the entrances, Sam watched the display of the system and Apophis’s guard fleet while she mentally counted down.

Almost on the mark, the first wave of the frigates dropped out of hyperspace and immediately engaged the enemy. A few seconds later, the display was filled with emergency alerts and damage notices, followed by Ha’taks disappearing.

No surprise there - a Horde frigate outclassed a Ha’tak, and even with the frigates serving as troop transporters and their escorts hanging back, the task force significantly outnumbered the enemy. The outcome was never in doubt. One by one, the Goa’uld ships blew up or were crippled under the coordinated fire.

The two Ha’taks in orbit were no exception - the one in geostationary orbit over the base was literally shot to pieces that burnt up in the atmosphere while the remains of the one above the pole crashed into the main landmass of the planet.

And then the second wave, transporting the troops, moved in, entering the planet’s orbit, shuttles detaching and heading down.

Sam didn’t think they would arrive in time to contribute to the taking of the base. But they could secure it so Sam, Entrapta and Bow could start looking into what experiments the research station had been running - and figure out how to undo them and get Catra back.

*****

Unknown Location, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Catra!"

Catra's ears twitched, and she drew back a little at the venom in Adora's voice. Her lover didn't show any relief at having found her - or any worry. "Ah… yes?" She managed to smile a little and started to raise her hand to wave. "It's…"

In the blink of an eye, Adora was in her face, one hand gripping her wrist like a vice.

"...me-OW!" Catra hissed through clenched teeth and resisted the urge to claw at Adora's arm. "Adora! What are you…"

"No more!" Adora buried her fist in Catra's stomach.

Eyes wide open, Catra coughed, almost folding around the blow. What the…?

"No more talking!"

The hand that had been holding her wrist now closed around her throat, preventing her from breathing. Catra gripped Adora's wrist with both hands but couldn't budge it.

"No more hurting!"

I don't know - I'm hurting badly right now. Catra would have laughed at her own thought if she'd had the breath for it.

"No more fighting!"

Don't claw her! Catra told herself as she struggled to loosen Adora's grip enough so she could breathe.

"It's over! You lost!"

No. Please. Adora… Catra moved her lips but couldn't talk. Couldn't get her throat free. Could only stare at Adora's furious - no, scornful - expression as she slowly started to fade.

And she couldn't help wondering if she deserved this.

*****

When Catra woke up, her first reaction was surprise that she was still alive. Or was she? Then she felt the pain. Her throat, stomach and wrist hurt. *Breathing* hurt. She coughed, which hurt some more, and tried to breathe as softly as she could as she gingerly touched her throat with her good hand. Damn, Adora had really put the hurt on her.

She looked around. She was in a large room. In a force field inside a large room. And the style of the room…

"Bright Moon," she whispered, wincing at the pain.

She was in a cell in Bright Moon.

But how? And Adora… She had been wearing the wrong uniform. And… she had acted so… Was she in some alternate universe, as Sam and Entrapta had speculated about sometimes? Or… Had she somehow been transported back in time to the Horde War? And displaced to Etheria? Was that even possible?

Of course, it is possible! This was a First Ones research station. She scoffed at her own doubts, then clenched her teeth at the pain. Damn. If she wasn't dead - she still wouldn't rule that out - then she had come damn close. And at the hands of Adora. An Adora, at least. Not her Adora. Her Adora wouldn't do that to her. Not even if Catra deserved it.

She slowly got up, wincing at the pain in her lower body. Her fur would hide bruises, but she would still feel them. She hoped she wasn't bleeding internally. Though… If she had been taken prisoner, wouldn't Bright Moon's healers have looked her over? If

only to ensure she didn't die before she was interrogated? Or judged?

But wouldn't they have fixed her throat, at least? She used her good hand to check her uniform. Of course, they had taken all the gear she'd been carrying. But they had left her the armoured uniform. Not that it would do any good against Adora.

She almost snorted but managed to control herself before she hurt her own throat some more. She was standing on a mattress. Just like she liked it - thin and solid, not like the fluffy pillows that Bright Moon's people called beds. But was that a kindness, or did her captors think it would be uncomfortable for her? Adora should know better than that, should she?

If this was a sign that her lover still cared about her… She smiled at the thought. Then frowned at her own foolishness. That expression on Adora's face… There had been no love. No care. No regret. Only judgement.

And Catra deserved to be judged. Especially if she was back in the Horde War. The things she had done…

The door sliding open interrupted her thoughts. She turned, clenching her teeth at the pain in her stomach and trying not to show it as she faced whoever had entered.

Adora. Or maybe She-Ra was more appropriate.

Catra swallowed - which hurt - as the other woman approached the force field. "Hey, Adora," she said without thinking.

She earned a glare and a deep scowl in return. "The Queen will see you. Don't even think of trying to escape."

She wasn't stupid. This might not be a dungeon, but the odds of escaping She-Ra here, and in her present state, were too low to risk it. If she was even going to try, of course. It wasn't as if she was innocent. And she had nothing to flee to - certainly not the Horde.

“The Queen? Glimmer?” Catra asked as Adora reached out and deactivated the force field.

“What? No. Queen Angella, of course!”

Oh, fuck!

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Enjoyed taking over the base, Carter?” Jack O’Neill grinned when he saw her enter the command centre, hiding his relief. Getting split up - unintentionally, even - was always bad. If Carter had gone missing… Well, she hadn’t. But if she had, Jack would probably have reacted… badly.

“Sir.” She nodded at him. Curtly. But he thought he caught a smile there. Good.

“Oh! This is a nice laboratory!” Entrapta said as she joined them. “Like Alpha! Did you standardise your research stations, Beta?””

The projection slightly turned. “Within reason. Depending on a station’s purpose, customised equipment and layouts are required.”

“Of course!” Entrapta nodded. “And this station was made to research interdimensional travel! How fascinating!”

“Yes.” Beta barely nodded. “I hope that with the change of command, serious research can finally be resumed.”

“Of course! We will do science to save Catra and the others!”

Jack winced. Entrapta’s enthusiasm paired with Beta’s attitude was a concerning combination. They’d have to keep an eye on them. Carter would be on the ball, though - he could trust her.

“Jack!” Daniel smiled at him. “Troops are landing and taking control of the base.”

“I know, Daniel,” Jack replied, nodding at the communication console. “I’m following the chatter.”

“Oh, of course.” Daniel looked a little sheepish for a moment. “You’re going up, then?”

Jack hesitated a moment. He wanted to go up and handle the landings, but someone Beta accepted as its superior had to stay here. Just in case. “When Adora relieves me.” On the other hand, Adora wasn’t completely herself right now, with Catra missing. If the bot pushed the right buttons, things could turn bad as well. He’d have to trust Bow and Glimmer to handle her if that should be the case.

“Taweret.” Sha’re walked towards the force-field-thingie that kept the snake prisoner.

The snake glared at her. “Amaunet. You’re working with the Tau’ri.”

“No.” Sha’re’s smile reminded Jack that she wasn’t the sweet girl who had fallen for an awkward archaeologist on Abydos any more. “I am Sha’re.”

The snake bared her teeth. “That won’t fool…” She trailed off as her eyes widened, glancing at the others in the room. “You’re the host?”

Sha’re nodded. “I am free once more.”

The snake drew back a little before narrowing her eyes. “How? You would be… The Tok’ra!”

Jack pressed his lips together. That was the kind of information the snakes really shouldn’t have. If Taweret escaped and told

Apophis that they were working with the Tok'ra, that would complicate things. Although Taweret had also seen She-Ra in action and knew that she was a First One. Well, the snake wouldn't be allowed to escape anyway.

"Amaunet is still alive. If you wish to survive, you will cooperate," Sha're said. "If you kill your host, you will share their fate."

"The Tok'ra don't take prisoners - they kill us!"

Sha're shook her head. "You can see Aumanet yourself."

And now the snake would know that the Tok'ra weren't calling the shots in this alliance. Well, if it was to save the poor girl serving as the host of the snake, that was OK.

Jack ignored the small voice in the back of his head telling him that the host was apparently a true believer and might turn traitor on them. This wasn't how the Alliance did things.

"Can you modify the force fields so Taweret cannot hear us?" Carter asked.

"I can," Beta replied, then looked at Jack.

Right. Of course. Jack rolled his eyes. "Yeah, do that."

A moment later, the force field turned slightly opaque. "The prisoner cannot hear or observe us any more," the bot announced.

Beta could have done that before, Jack knew. And he was sure that the bot was smart enough to think of it - or suggest it, just as it had made suggestions before. So, why hadn't it done so? Was this a ploy to ensure Taweret knew too much to be allowed to live? Or some sort of twisted test to judge how smart they were? In case Beta had another option to take over the lab?

Whatever the answer, they couldn't trust the bot. Not too far, at least. It had an agenda.

“So…” Entrapta glanced up from where she had been staring at one of the holoprojectors serving as screens. “You have a projector that transports a target area into another dimension. And you can vary the size of the target area and deploy it within a long range - not enough to reach another planet in the system, but if this planet had a moon, you could reach it.”

“That is correct,” Beta said.

“And you have been using it as a weapon against ships and were researching a way to install it on a ship,” Carter added.

“Yes.”

“But you’re struggling with the side-effects destabilising the ship itself as the dimensional breach weakens the fabric of reality.” Entrapta nodded. “It’s not much of a structural problem unless you dial up the power used, but it wrecks the crystal matrices controlling the portal - and most electronics. And since the target area is variable, you can’t install fields to block that interference because the field projectors don’t have that range.”

“Yes.” Jack wasn’t sure, but Beta looked more attentive now. “You have experience with this technology.”

“Well… kinda? I helped build an extradimensional portal. But it wasn’t stable, so the first test run kinda almost destroyed the entire world.” Entrapta looked a bit sheepish. “We haven’t done much work in that area since that. It was deemed too dangerous.”

“Until now.” Beta smiled.

Jack frowned. He really didn’t like that smile.

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Apophis's Base, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“We’ve finished taking control of the base, Ma’am!”

“Thank you, Major.” Adora nodded with a smile. Her smile slipped at the thought that if Catra were here, she’d make a comment that the base was already secure and the landing forces had just to walk into the base and reach the key locations. Depending on her mood, it would be a quiet whisper to Adora or a comment to the Major in charge of the troops - well, under Jack, of course; those were his people.

But since Catra was missing, Major Martin merely nodded again - Jack had drilled all his people to avoid saluting in the field even though anyone could pick out Adora as the leader here - and left for his command post.

That left Adora to check the reports from the task force. They had secured the planet’s orbit and finished boarding the enemy ships that hadn’t been destroyed outright in the battle. Fortunately, the Jaffa in the crippled ships hadn’t managed to blow up their vessels to deny them to the Alliance, but as far as Adora could tell from the first reports, the reason for that success was that the task force’s frigates had destroyed the main reactors of the ships in question at the same time the engines had been hit. That probably meant that repairing the ships wouldn’t be cost-efficient unless the Alliance wanted a Ha’tak for a special operation. Operating Goa’uld ships would also strain logistics for no real gain, and if you refitted them with Alliance tech, you might as well just build a new ship.

But that wasn’t important right now. The system was under Alliance control, as was the planet - not that there was anything to control except for the base and the research station, anyway. And the camp they were setting up for the freed slaves, though that would take a while.

Still, things were in hand. And communications had been restored as well, though as soon as they used the portal to get Catra back, their comms would be down again. Well, if they didn’t figure out a way to shield their regular communicators from the effects of the projector, they would just have to replace them again.

Anyway, it was time to get Catra back. Or, Adora corrected herself, to start getting her back. She looked at the soldiers in the security centre. “I’m returning to the research station. Major Martins is in command.”

“Yes, ma’am!”

She walked - even though she wanted to hurry, running would have sent the wrong message to the soldiers - to the transporter room and told the officer in charge there: “Take me to the research station.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

A moment later, she was back in the station and on the way to the command centre. She passed a set of guards - Campbel and Isa - and entered the room.

“Supreme Commander Adora, you’ve returned!” Beta addressed her. “Research Station Beta is at your disposal.”

Adora frowned. The way everyone else was glaring at Beta before looking at her was a sure sign that something was wrong. “So… what’s going on?” she asked.

“Beta insists on using people as test subjects!” Sam blurted out.

What? Hadn’t Adora made it clear that they wouldn’t use people for their experiments?

Beta nodded. “Without using appropriate test subjects, the odds of recovering your friend are significantly reduced. I’ve explained this, but your subordinates do not accept it.”

“We can use bots as test subjects. And animals,” Sam said.

“Neither bots nor animals are an adequate substitute. The experiment requires a sapient mind to align with the target dimension,” Beta retorted.

“What?” Adora also stared at Beta. “But you’ve used it on ships!”

Beta nodded. “When used as a weapon system, such as against ships, recovering the targets afterwards, or ensuring that they were not destroyed in the process, wasn’t a consideration. Unlike when transporting people.”

“Doesn’t sound as if recovering the ‘test subjects’ was a priority either,” Jack commented.

“Not under the prior commander,” Beta said.

“But why do you need a sapient target?” Entrapta asked. “Don’t you just connect two dimensions? We didn’t need anything like that when we created the Portal.”

“And Mara transported an entire solar system to an alternate dimension,” Adora pointed out.

“That is very impressive. Any data from her experiment would be critically important for our research here,” Beta commented.

Adora shook her head. “All the data was destroyed in the process. Now explain why you need people as test subjects.”

Beta hesitated a moment, and Adora narrowed her eyes. That was suspicious! Then Beta inclined her head. “The projector does not target alternate dimensions directly. It uses a different dimension to reach them. One that is very receptive to alterations caused by people’s thoughts. Only sapient beings can be prepared for this.”

“That makes no sense!” Sam objected. “Why would you set things up like this? We’ve checked the data - the computer controlling the projector is perfectly capable of selecting alternate dimensions. You don’t need to go through this hypothetical transfer dimension.”

“The First Ones who built this station set the parameters for the experiment,” Beta replied. “I lack the authorisation to change them.”

“Well, so Adora can change them, right?” Jack said.

Beta turned to look at Adora. “Doing so would render the goal of recovering your friend impossible since she went missing in the original target dimension.”

“Oh.” Entrapta blinked.

Adora clenched her teeth. She couldn’t abandon Catra. But she couldn’t sacrifice others to save her, either. What should she do? What could she do?

“Why did the First Ones pick that special dimension?” Bow asked.

Beta didn’t answer him.

Adora frowned. “Answer the question, Beta.”

“Very well.” Beta almost seemed to sigh. “This research station was built to find an alternate way to *ascend*.”

Adora blinked. What?

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Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Ascend?” Samantha Carter hadn’t heard this term before - not in relation to alternate universes.

“What is that?” Adora asked a moment later.

“To ascend is to reach a higher plane of existence, leaving this universe behind. According to my data, ascension grants the subject undergoing it great knowledge and power and eternal life,” Beta replied. “However, the process has strict requirements - mental, spiritual and evolutionary. And once ascended, the subject cannot interact or influence this universe ever again.”

“That sounds like the kind of promise made by a cult leader - if there’s no way to report back, no one can prove it’s a scam,” the General commented.

Sam had to agree - this seemed to be a rather questionable process.

“It doesn’t sound very different from what several major religions on Earth proclaim,” Entrapta pointed out.

“That’s different,” the General snapped.

“How so?” Entrapta asked. “Many of them seem to promise a life in paradise after death.”

“The existence of Ascension has been proven, and the process has been observed many times - most of the Ancestors of the First Ones ascended,” Beta said.

“If it exists and works, why do you need an alternative?” Daniel asked.

“Fulfilling the requirements is challenging, and the Ascension itself is a lengthy process,” Beta told him. “My creators wished to facilitate it. Another goal was to find a way to reach the higher planes without eliminating the possibility of returning to this universe.”

That sounded like the Ancients might have had doubts about the entire process despite Beta’s claim that it was proven to work, in Sam’s opinion.

“Well, according to one of Earth’s religions, finding enlightenment is supposed to be a process that takes several lives,” Daniel said. “And, err, this sounds like a similar process. There might be shared roots, actually, for the concepts.”

The General snorted. “So, the First Ones didn’t want to abandon all earthly desires to ascend, huh?”

"I cannot comment on my creator's goals except for what I was told," Beta replied.

"I'll take that as a 'yes', then."

"Jack!"

"I'm calling it like I'm seeing it."

Daniel shook his head at the General. "You can't just assume that the Ancients were like us - they had a vastly different and more advanced culture. You shouldn't project our own morals and way of thinking on them or you'll make incorrect assumptions."

"Didn't seem like they were too different from us," Glimmer commented.

"Well, technologically, they were far ahead of us," Entrapta said.

"We're talking about their morals," Glimmer retorted. "They were willing to destroy Etheria to beat Horde Prime."

That was something many humans would have done as well, Sam had to admit. Some would have done it just to deny the world to the enemy. But Daniel was also correct - they couldn't just treat the Ancients as humans with better technology.

"Did you send Catra to those 'higher planes of existence'?" Adora asked.

Sam glanced at her and winced - her friend looked like she wanted to break something. Maybe Beta.

"No," Beta replied, seemingly unaware of the tension. "The experiment is still in the early stages. The dimension focused upon shares some characteristics with the higher planes of existence, according to our data. Mainly, that sapient minds can easily influence and shape it when exposed to it."

Sam frowned. She couldn't help doubting this.

Bow asked: “Why would sapience be required for that?”

“Lesser life forms are ruled by instincts and emotions. In order to ascend, you have to overcome both,” Beta said.

“That sounds like straight out of a self-help book,” the General said.

“It has been verified through experimentation, General O’Neill,” Beta told him.

“I wonder what kind of experimentation that was,” he retorted.

“Do you wish to access the data?”

“Ah… maybe later.” And now he looked sheepish.

But Sam understood the reaction - some of the Ancients’ experiments were beyond the pale. And she still hadn’t heard a good reason for not using animals as test subjects. “But even if you need sapient minds to influence the dimension, you could use animals to test the transporting process.”

“They would not deliver any new data. In order to retrieve a test subject, the projector relies on finding them through the changes they effect in the dimension compared to the base parameters.”

“You’re using their effects on the environment to find them?” Bow asked. “Like, tracking their steps?”

“It’s a crude approximation, but essentially, yes,” Beta replied.

“Well, finding Catra shouldn’t be hard then - she tends to leave a huge impact wherever she goes,” Glimmer joked.

Adora didn’t laugh, though. “What is the problem then? Why do you need more test subjects?”

“While we have managed to track such changes, we have not yet managed to find a test subject to recover. The current hypothesis

is that the process of tracking them takes too long to lock on to them."

Entrapta cocked her head. "I think we need to see the data for that."

Sam nodded in agreement.

*****

Unknown Location, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"You know, I'm not going to run," Catra commented, trying to sound far more confident than she felt, when Adora grabbed her upper arm and all but dragged her towards the throne room.

"Yeah, right."

Catra suppressed a wince at the cold tone. "It would be pointless, wouldn't it? With you here, surrounded by guards, in the middle of Bright Moon…"

"That never stopped you before!"

That was true. The stupid things Catra had done in the past… "I've changed," she replied.

Adora scoffed in return. "I know you. You won't ever change."

Catra pressed her lips together and tried not to show how that hurt. This wasn't her Adora. She had to remind herself of that. She was in some alternate dimension or whatever. Her Adora knew her. Loved her.

She tried to shrug while they turned a corner. "I changed my hairstyle."

Catra almost stumbled when Adora stopped walking and turned to look at her. "That doesn't change anything!" she spat before turning away and continuing on.

That's weird, Catra thought. Adora had acted as if she hadn't noticed Catra's hairstyle before. Of course, it was just a new hairstyle - and she had lost her Horde headgear, couldn't forget that - but still… Catra would have noticed any change in Adora right away. And had as soon as she had seen this Adora.

Maybe this Adora didn't care enough about Catra to pay attention to such details. That hurt a bit more.

Maybe she's not as obsessed with you as you are with her? Maybe she has finally realised how worthless you are? a voice that sounded like Shadow Weaver whispered in the back of her head.

Catra clenched her teeth and hissed under her breath. She wasn't worthless! And Adora wouldn't do that!

Adora snorted. “Realised you can't escape, huh?”

Catra pressed her lips together. Adora had misunderstood her reaction. But she wasn't about to correct her. “I realised that from the start,” she replied.

Adora just sneered in return.

They reached their destination before Catra could think of anything else to say. The guards at the entrance stepped to the side and opened the doors, revealing the throne room, and Catra had to suppress another hiss.

Angella was sitting on her throne, Glimmer standing at her side, both wearing… full regalia, was the term, probably. A dozen guards lined the carpet leading to the throne. And most of the Princess Alliance seemed to be clustered on both sides of the throne. Bow, Perfuma, Mermista, Spinnerella, Netossa and Frosta, who was still a preteen brat. No Entrapta, though. No Scorpia, either, but that was to be expected. Yeah, this must be before the portal. So…

Catra froze as she spotted another figure there, back in the corner to the side, flanked by two guards.

Shadow Weaver.

“What's *she* doing here?” she hissed halfway to the throne.

“Silence!” Adora spat.

She wasn't going to stay silent! Not with that snake in the room! But Adora tightened her grip on Catra's upper arm and pulled her along.

As soon as they reached the throne, Adora pushed Catra ahead. “I’ve brought the prisoner!”

“Thank you!” Angella smiled at Adora before scowling at Catra. Like everyone else here.

Catra clenched her teeth and straightened. She couldn't lose her temper. Not here. She had weathered worse. Those weren't the princesses she knew, anyway. Unless this was the past, of course. She focused on Angella and bowed her head. “Your majesty.”

“Catra.”

Catra suppressed a wince at the icy tone. So much scorn in a single word! “Yes.” She swallowed a quip about not wearing out her name. She had to be diplomatic. This wasn't her world. Not her Adora.

Angella sniffed and went on. “The leader of the Horde. The woman who commanded the invasions of our kingdoms. The fool who almost destroyed the entire world in her crazed lust for power!”

Catra flinched - she had done that. And more. She swallowed, then straightened again, She could man up to her past. “Yes.”

“You admit it.”

“No point in lying.” Catra managed to shrug. “I know what I did.”

“And you're proud of it!” Angella spat.

“What? No!” Catra shook her head. “I'm not proud of it.”

“Liar.”

Catra jerked - Shadow Weaver had spoken up. She had forgotten about the woman's presence for a moment.

“I know you,” Shadow Weaver went on. “You're full of pride even if the only thing you've achieved is hurting people.”

“You don't know me!” Catra spat.

“I raised you.” Shadow Weaver glided forward. Even with the mask, Catra knew she was sneering at her. “I know you better than you know yourself. I know what a failure and disappointment you are.”

“I’m not a failure!”

Catra only realised that she had taken a few steps towards the miserable old witch when Adora's hand closed around her arm again. It took all of Catra's self-control not to curse at Shadow Weaver. She was better than that.

“Enough. You've admitted your guilt. We will decide on your punishment.” Angella nodded at Adora. “Please take her back to her cell.”

Catra's eyes widened. That was far too quick! “Wait! I'm not the Catra you know!” she blurted out. “I’m from another dimension!”

Adora didn't stop dragging her away, but when Catra looked over her shoulder, she saw Angella gasp and stare at her.

“You've got the wrong Catra!”

Adora snorted at that. The entire Alliance present laughed. Except for Angella. The woman didn't say anything and just kept staring

at her until the doors closed behind Catra and Adora.

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The Secret Base Part 5

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

The more he heard about the Ancients, the less Jack O'Neill liked them. Well, it would be more honest to say that he liked them even less - he hadn't had a good opinion of them for a long time now. That some of their robots thought he was one of them didn't change that. Quite the contrary. Between their crazy experiments and dangerous tech thingies that they just kept lying around, it was a wonder that the Galaxy was still standing.

And he couldn't help feeling that Beta here was working on changing that. "So… if I remember correctly, the last time someone tinkered with a portal like that, they almost blew up reality, right?"

Judging by the looks from Carter and Daniel, his Columbo impression needed some work. Or it was because Entrapta cringed at his comment, he realised with a wince. He hadn't wanted to hurt her - criticising her, even when it was perfectly justified, made Jack feel like he shot Bambi's mom. Well, when she actually took his criticism to heart and didn't misunderstand it.

"Well, it's debatable how far the effect would have spread, but as far as Etheria in Despondos was concerned, reality would have been destroyed, yes," Entrapta said after a moment. "Though since that was an alternate dimension, it might have been contained." She blinked. "Actually, if we take the new data from Beta into account - though we still need to study it; we just got the synopsis from Beta, so to speak, even though I trust her - then this might not have been the end of reality but more a merging of the two dimensions and the aspects of the other dimension dominating Despondos's reality. Of course, that would require that we connected to the same or a similar dimension as the one Beta is targeting."

Jack almost snapped that experimenting further was too dangerous and they should destroy the lab. The only thing that held him back was knowing that Adora wouldn't abandon Catra. And suspecting that Beta would use that to influence Adora and sideline Jack. Also, taking risks to save a friend was not the same as risking the galaxy to become gods or whatever - he wasn't Daniel, but Jack knew what Ascension meant in that context. And Carter would probably never forgive him if he destroyed the lab here.

Still, someone had to point out the danger. "So, what are the odds that we get another such merge here?" Jack asked.

"We don't know if that happened back in Despondos!" Entrapta pointed out. "It's just a possibility. Of course, we did use a lot of First Ones tech there, which probably came from this lab, but we also used Horde tech, so we need to examine the data here and compare it to what data we have left from the Horde to tell!" She perked up. "Oh, we really need to get my science buddy here! He might remember more because it was his project at the start!"

Yeah, the clone of a warlord with a god complex is just the thing a laboratory where aliens planned to get an easy way to become gods is missing, Jack thought.

"Yes!" Adora nodded firmly.

"Indeed," Beta agreed. "Horde Prime displayed and deployed very impressive technology in the war against our people. It would be only fitting if that technology would be used to continue the experiments here."

So much for Jack's hope that the Ancient bot would make Adora and Entrapta mad by trying to oppose Hordak coming here. That would have made Adora distrust the bot, at least. "That might take a while," he said. "We shouldn't run experiments without him, then."

"We need time to review the data here anyway," Carter added.

He could see Adora biting her lower lip. She obviously didn't want to hear that but didn't want to object. Good. The last thing they needed was a crazy bot running experiments that could ruin reality itself. Jack liked his reality being real.

"Yes!" Entrpata nodded emphatically. "Let's start on that! Beta, can you point us to a data terminal with enough workspace?

"Yes. Please follow me." The projection turned and led them towards one of the doors in the back.

Jack looked at Bow, but the boy was already following them. Good. Jack trusted Carter, of course, but she could get caught up in her work sometimes. Another grounded tech head helping them wouldn't hurt.

"Don't worry - we'll get Catra back," Glimmer told Adora.

"Yes." Adora nodded, but her expression belied her words.

"We're like the Marines in that - we don't leave anyone behind," Jack added. And hoped he wasn't lying through his teeth.

Though he hoped even harder that the whole thing here wouldn't end in a catastrophe.

*****

Captured Base, PU-9623, January 30th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Adora had to be patient. Rushing things would not help anyone - would even endanger everyone since they were working with dimensional portals. Entrapta and Sam were geniuses who knew what they were doing, but they needed time to study Beta's data before they could start the recovery operation.

Adora knew that. Knew that very well. But the longer they waited, the longer Catra was missing, the greater the danger was that something would happen to her. Something else. Something more

dangerous than being transported into a weird dimension. They had to save her, as quickly as possible.

But she also knew that Beta had lost track of every test subject the bot had sent into the other dimension - and had lost track of Catra as well. Even if they were willing to risk it, they couldn't just start the recovery attempt. It wouldn't do any good.

And yet, waiting, unable to do anything for Catra, was unbearable.

Adora clenched her teeth. She should sleep - it was past midnight, at least according to Alliance Time on Earth, and Glimmer had already taken over Taweret's bedroom while the others, except for Bow, Entrapta and Sam, had found places to sleep themselves - but Adora knew she wouldn't be able to rest. Not with her lover missing. She had to keep busy until her friends finished - there was no time to lose. And she was She-Ra; she could handle an all-nighter.

Also, it wasn't as if there was nothing to do - as Supreme Commander of the Alliance, she always had paperwork to do. And thanks to the spy bot network, it followed her onto missions such as this as well - sometimes even in actual paper form when they used Stargates.

But having the work and doing the work were not the same. Leaning back in what apparently had been Taweret's office in her quarters, Adora sighed. Reading reports that were mostly updates of earlier reports, and generally confirmed the projections, wasn't helping much. Especially since the lack of scathing commentary reminded her of Catra's absence with every report she read.

There were several important - or more important - reports, of course, some concerning the latest fleet trials, but none of them required immediate action except for referring them to her staff for analysis. The British were making more progress, the Americans were still dealing with problems with their 'light battle carriers' - a designation for the design Adora didn't think would

last much longer than its predecessor 'light multirole cruiser' - and the French were a bit behind because they were leading the shared European design for a frigate and just coordinating half a dozen requests and requirements apparently took a lot of time even if they were mostly copying the British designs.

Perhaps she should have insisted on launching more Horde frigates instead of everyone designing their own ships. But everyone wanted the ability and knowledge to build spaceships on their own, so…

A beep announced another E-Mail. She checked it - ah, the first formal after-action report from the task force had arrived. A bit of skimming later, she winced. She would have thought that any of the mistakes made in the first landing operation wouldn't be repeated, but she had been wrong. The need for more training, especially coordinating between different forces, was evident.

She wrote a quick memo and sent it to her staff to check, then went over the supply requests - just to check that nothing was being forgotten; Jack's people were handling that.

And as expected from Jack's force, everything was in order. Maybe she should check up on the news from Earth…

Or she could check on the prisoners. The Jaffa, as expected from the most loyal and fanatical of Apophis's forces, had usually fought until death, but there had been exceptions. Some were knocked out, but others had surrendered when facing her. Adora should see how they were doing.

But what were the odds that some of them would pray to her? Atak did, and the way a few of the prisoners had looked at her when they had been taken, Adora didn't think Atak was the only one mistaking her for a goddess here. Maybe she should sleep on that before meeting them.

Stifling a yawn, she started on the rest of the paperwork - mostly informative, non-crucial messages and memos. Like the food

consumption reports - with the usual complaints about the MREs that made her roll her eyes; if those people had ever eaten Horde rations…

Another message interrupted her. Oh! It was from Sam - they had finished reviewing the data!

Adora jumped up and rushed toward the transporter room.

Catra, we're coming to save you!

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 30th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"You finished going over the data?"

Samantha Carter turned and looked at Adora - her friend had blurted her question out as soon as she had entered the main laboratory of Beta. "We have finished our preliminary review of the research data," Sam corrected her.

"Oh."

"Yes. But we already have a lot of ideas!" Entrapta added, nodding with a slight smile.

"Speculation," Beta said. "But well-reasoned speculation based on the analysis done. I cannot disprove the conclusions."

"It's fascinating data." Entrapta grimaced. "Although there are also a few concerning data points. Kinda."

"Concerning?" Adora's eyes widened as she approached them at a fast pace. "How concerning?"

She must not have been resting, Sam realised. Not that Sam could throw stones here - she had worked through herself, as had Entrapta and Bow, who had gone to personally wake up Glimmer.

“Well…” Entrapta started to say, wincing under Adora's stare.

They should wait for the others, in Sam's opinion, but with Adora in such a state… “We analysed the data of the past tracking attempts, and there might be outside interference,” she explained.

Adora gasped before pressing her lips together for a moment. “Outside interference?”

“Yes,” Beta said with a deep scowl. “They're interfering with the experiment!”

Sam rolled her eyes at the bot's apparent priorities. “The data indicates that tracking - albeit indirectly - works at the start, I mean, shortly after arrival at the destination. And there's no sign of the compiled tracking data deteriorating over time - while the original effects on the environment recorded by the station’s sensors seem to fade in time, they are continually renewed and partially replaced.”

“As predicted,” Beta cut in. “Though due to outside interference, we lack the data to track long-term effects of sapient minds - where the effects can stabilise or even become self-sustaining is still in doubt.”

“The data tracks until it stops and vanishes,” Entrapta added. “And it always happens after about the same time has passed there - except for the first few attempts, where it took longer.”

Adora didn't look reassured. “But you need a sapient mind to affect the dimension, right?”

“Yes.” Beta firmly nodded.

Sam had her doubts that this was entirely correct, but this wasn't the time to discuss this. But Adora had raised another point or seemed to be about to. Best nip that in the bud. “We don't think that this means the people transported there die at that point,” she said. “They disappear too quickly for environmental influence.”

“And there's a spike right before the effect ends and starts to fade - a very distinct spike,” Entrapta added. “One that looks almost identical in over a dozen cases. The pattern is clear and nearly identical, while the patterns generated by the test subjects often vary significantly.”

“The most probable explanation is that someone is removing the people from the dimension we're tracking or from their location there,” Sam took over again. Or, though she didn't say that, someone was hunting down new arrivals and killed them very quickly.

Even so, Adora looked grim. “Removing them - for what reason?”

“Perhaps they want to save them?” Entrapta’s hopeful smile slowly died as Adora looked at her.

“We don't know yet. But barring some truly exotic environmental effect, we believe this is outside interference,” Sam said.

“And it shows that recovering people from that dimension is possible.” Entrapta was really trying to console their friend.

Adora slowly nodded. “Did that happen to Catra as well?”

“Yes. We've analysed the data from the attack, and while it's not as detailed as the other readings, it tracks as well,” Entrapta said.

“I couldn't use the sensors to the best of their capabilities since I lacked the necessary preparation time for the experiment.” Beta inclined her head. “The prior administration was not overly interested in proper documentation.” Her tone made this sound like the worst of Taweret's crime, Sam noted.

“So, what can we do with this?” Adora asked. “How can we get Catra and the others back?”

Sam suppressed a wince at her friend's expression. Adora looked both hopeful and desperate.

“Now that we have identified the interference, we can plan to deal with it,” Beta said.

“We haven't actually identified the interference,” Entrapta pointed out. “We just know that something is interfering.”

“And we need to recover the people who vanished from wherever they happened to be taken to,” Sam reminded Beta.

“Yes, of course.” Beta nodded. “But that will require dealing with the interference as well. I suggest sending an armed test subject next, to see if they can fend off the interference. Even if unsuccessful, the data should reveal if they can temporarily delay the interference.”

“We're not using people as test subjects!” Adora snapped.

Beta looked puzzled, cocking her head to the side. “I was under the impression that volunteers would be acceptable. And from what I gathered, many of your followers would volunteer to help recover your consort, Adora.”

Adora gaped. “That's… That's… I won't ask that of them!” she blurted out.

Beta looked confused. “Would you refuse their help to save your consort? Even if freely offered?”

“That's… why would they offer in the first place?” Adora asked.

“It's an obvious solution to the lack of test subjects,” Beta replied.

Before Sam could think of what to say to that - and how to deal with her suspicion that Beta had been busy gathering as much information about Adora as possible - the others arrived, led by Glimmer.

“You finished going over the data?” Glimmer blurted out, mirroring Adora.

“I told you that!” Bow said behind her.

“We did,” Sam told them.

“But we have a problem,” Adora said. With a glance at Beta, she added: “A bunch of them.”

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Unknown Location, January 30th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Look, I'm not your Carta! I'm from another universe - or another dimension!”

A scoff answered her. “Really? That's the best you can come up with?”

“It's the truth!” she insisted.

“Is that why you cut your hair? To make us believe you?”

“My hair was cut by Horde Prime!” She shivered at the memory. Or not-memory - it was a bit hazy.

“Horde Prime?” Another scoff. “Making up Horde members now? It's not working.”

“Horde Prime was Hordak's leader - his commander. He was the leader of the entire Horde. He had a fleet of spaceships and tried to destroy Etheria. In my universe.”

“Really, Catra, this is just pathetic. Bad lies and a bad haircut won't save you from the consequences of your actions.”

“Bad haircut? Adora - my Adora loves it!” She did! She knew it.

Laughter. They were almost back at her cell now. “It's ugly. And you claim ‘your Adora’ loves it? Is she a Horde Adora, huh?” The eyes narrowed into a glare. “Wait… Are you talking about your perfect world? The world for which you almost destroyed Etheria? That's pathetic, Catra.”

“No!” She shook her head and clenched her teeth. She wasn't pathetic! “In my universe, things went differently. We defeated the Horde. Adora saved us all. She saved me!”

More scoffing followed. “Now you claim you fought the Horde? While still wearing their uniform? Catra, Catra, Catra… No one would be so foolish as to believe this. Just stop and show some dignity.” Laughter briefly filled the hallway. “No lies will save you. No one will save you.”

“Adora will,” she spat. She would! “She loves me!”

Wide eyes stared at her before the surprised expression turned into a sneer. “No one loves you, Catra. You're a monster without a conscience. And you will be punished for what you did!”

She gasped at that. It wasn't true. It wasn't! Adora loved her! “I'm not your Catra!”

But they were at the cell, and she was pushed inside with enough force to send her stumbling into the marked area in the centre. She looked over her shoulder, turning, as the force field sprang up around her, to appeal to Adora again, but she only saw the back of her as Adora walked out the door, leaving her behind.

Sitting in a corner of her cell, Catra took a deep breath. She should sleep instead of running through this in her mind. This hadn't been her Adora. She had to remind her of that. Her Adora would have listened. Her Adora loved her. She knew it. Her Adora would do everything to save her.

Catra just had to wait until she did. And survive. And she would. She could take whatever this world threw at her. She would. She would…

Her ears twitched, and she turned - the door was opening. In the middle of the night? She suppressed a gasp as hope filled her. Adora? Had she reconsidered Catra's claims? “Hey…”

She trailed off, her forced smile vanishing. It wasn't Adora who entered. It was Angella. Alone, without guards. And staring at her with a cold expression.

Catra had weathered worse, though. Much worse. Like Shadow Weaver. Or… Whatever! She rose and cocked her head to the side. "Visiting prisoners in the middle of the night, Your Majesty?"

Angella didn't say a word. Instead, her mouth twisted into a slight sneer for a moment as she approached until she was standing directly before the force field.

Catra frowned, pressing her lips together, and raised her head to meet Angella's eyes. The queen was far too tall for Glimmer's mother. "Come to pass the sentence? I thought you would have wanted to do that in the Throne Room. Make a spectacle," she said as dismissively as she could. She wouldn't beg. "Maybe followed by a public execution?" she added in a mocking tone despite the fear making her stomach clench. If they killed her… Bright Moon doesn't kill their prisoners, she reminded herself. Not even this Bright Moon - not when they didn't have actual dungeons here, either.

Angella still didn't answer. The queen walked around the force field, and Catra turned her head to follow her. Her back itched when the queen was directly behind her, but Catra didn't move except turning her head. She had to stay calm. Collected. In control. Even though she wasn't.

Angella completed the full circle, facing her again, then scoffed and slightly shook her head. "How did *you* end up here?"

Catra almost said: 'You had Adora lock me up here. Did you forget already?' before she managed to hold her tongue. She frowned instead - something was odd here. Wrong. But she couldn't tell what. So, best play along. Shrugging, she said: "I was shot with some First Ones weapon that threw me into this dimension. By an alien."

“Fitting.”

Catra shrugged again. “I got a bit too cocky. We've been rolling up their forces easily, too easily. Charged straight into their trap.” Better her than Adora, though. But she would have to do better next time. She couldn't get sloppy.

“Typical.” Angella sneered.

Catra suppressed a scowl. She was better than that - she wouldn't lose her temper at some petty comments. She had taken much worse from Shadow Weaver. “I blame hanging around with the Alliance for too long. It wouldn't have happened when I was still leading the Horde. But you know Adora - always charging in headfirst and making it work somehow. She's going to save me, by the way.” She had to.

“Adora? Save *you*?” Angella sneered even more.

“Yes.” Catra nodded and tried to show as much confidence as she could. “She saved me from Horde Prime before. You know her - she never abandons her friends.”

“You? Her friend? Liar!” Angella spat. “You hurt her - you hurt all of us. You are no one's friend.”

“That wasn't me!” Catra snarled. “I hurt my Adora, not yours. I'm not your Catra!”

“So you claim.” Angella drew back with a haughty expression. “And yet… You are the same, aren't you?”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “What do you mean?”

“You said you hurt ‘your Adora’. You did the same deeds, didn't you? You didn't deny it earlier, either, did you?”

Catra clenched her teeth. “That was in the past. I changed.” She had. She really had. Even if Angella wouldn’t believe her.

She frowned. Why was Angella here, alone, anyway? Why hadn't she taken Glimmer with her? Or Adora? Adora knew her - or the other Catra - best. She would have helped a lot with the interrogation. Why had the Queen of Bright Moon come to her cell at night, alone, like… Her eyes widened for a moment. “You are hiding something! From everyone! That's why you're here alone, at this time of the night!”

For a moment, Angella looked surprised. Then she straightened, and her lips twisted into a tight smile. “You are different. You aren't from here.”

“I told you that,” Catra spat. “I’m not your Catra!”

Angella's smile widened. “That still remains to be seen.”

Catra stared at her. What? What did she mean? This was… She drew a sudden, sharp breath. It couldn't be! But the woman hadn't doubted her about the First Ones weapon… “You stepped into the portal, didn't you?” she whispered.

Angella flashed her teeth at her as she nodded.

Damn. Catra felt a shiver run down her spine as her fur bristled. If this Angella was the one from her universe, then Catra was the one responsible for sending her here. “But the others…” She trailed off. This Adora wasn't *her* Adora.

“They're native to this dimension,” Angella replied. She narrowed her eyes. “But they have suffered at the Horde's hands as well.”

Catra flinched at that. Yeah, she wasn't proud of what she had done in the past. And yet… She frowned. “But what happened to the Catra from this dimension?” Her eyes widened. “And what happened to the Angella from this dimension?”

“They're gone,” Angella replied. “The entire Horde is gone. Only the memories of the war remain.”

“Gone? You defeated them?” Catra leaned forward, almost touching the force field. Sure, the Horde had been in a bad spot after the portal, but they had recovered and almost beaten the Alliance. “How did you do that? What about Horde Prime?”

“Who?”

Damn! “Horde Prime. I told Adora about him - he's the one who created the Horde in his own image - Hordak is a clone of him. He destroyed the First Ones,” Catra explained. “The portal alerted him to Despondos, and he invaded.” Right after everything had gone to hell. Right after the Alliance had taken the Fright Zone. “He didn't arrive here?”

“No.” Angella shook her head.

“So, you beat the Horde and the war was over? What happened to Scorpia and Entrapta?”

“The Horde is gone,” Angella repeated herself in a flat voice. “Only the memories remain.”

Catra flinched. That sounded bad. Really bad. “Did Adora…?” She trailed off. If this Adora had completely wiped out the Horde using her power... “What about the Heart of Etheria?”

“What is that?”

Catra tensed and wanted to curse some more. They hadn't dealt with it yet? “It's the First Ones superweapon meant to be used against Horde Prime. It would destroy Etheria when used - and it's controlled by She-Ra's sword. And it has been gathering magic power from the entire sector for a thousand years. If it's not stopped, it will destroy Etheria. It's activated when all of the Elemental Princesses connect to their runestones.”

Angella looked as if she didn't believe her. “That's not a problem in this world.”

“What? All it takes is the Princess of the Scorpion Kingdom connecting to the Black Garnet, and everything goes to pieces!” Catra blurted out.

“There is no such princess. The Scorpion Kingdom was destroyed by the Horde.”

“You haven't restored it? But…” Right. ‘Gone’. Scorpia was gone. But her family! “What did you do to the people? In the Horde? In the Fright Zone?” Catra asked.

“I told you - they're gone.”

Catra found herself kneeling on the floor, staring at Angella. “You… you killed them all?” That was monstrous! How could they do this?

“They're gone,” Angella said again. Catra could see her jaw muscles twitch as she clenched her teeth. “Only the memories of the war remain.”

Catra shook her head, blinking. “No wonder this Adora's so different. She must be traumatised by this.” Her Adora would have never done that. To kill so many people… She gasped. “Entrapta! What happened to her? She was on Beast Island, not in the Fright Zone!”

Angella frowned but didn't answer.

Catra blinked again to clear her eyes. They couldn't have wiped out the island if they didn't know about it, could they? “Beast Island! The place where the Horde banished the worst prisoners! Entrapta's there - and Micah!”

Angella recoiled as if Catra had struck her. “Micah's dead!” she yelled. “Killed by the Horde! Killed by you!”

“No! He's on Beast Island. Adora and the others found him there when they rescued Entrapta!” Catra retorted. “Send them there and look for Entrapta and Micah!”

“You lie!” Angella spat. “Micah's dead! You killed him!” She turned around and quickly walked to the door.

“They're on Beast Island!” Catra yelled after her. “Save them!”

Angella didn't answer and didn't look back.

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Captured Base, PU-9623, January 30th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill felt as if he was back at Stargate Command during a crisis. He was trying to keep busy while Carter worked desperately on alien technology to save the day. Only, he wasn't the leader of SG-1 any more, hovering around her lab and trying to ensure that she didn't work herself to death. He was a general in charge of Special Forces Command of the Alliance - and the second-in-command of the entire mission to this planet.

Of course, back in Stargate Command under General Hammond, he would have been in charge of the entire mission as leader of SG-1, but the mission here was a tiny bit bigger. SG-1 hadn't done any planetary invasions.

Well, it meant he didn't have to feel completely useless while he waited for Carter, Entrapta and Bow to find a way to get Catra and the ‘Test Subjects’ back from another dimension. He had to turn the fortress they had taken from Apophis's forces into an Alliance base that could protect the research station below it. At least until the Alliance found some other general to take over. Jack and his people were Special Forces, not garrison troopers.

Still, watching as combat engineers tore out the snake queen's luxury furnishings to install proper quarters and offices was satisfying. All the pomp and waste finally… “Hey!” he snapped. “Put that into the crate! No souvenir hunting!”

The soldier who had been about to palm a golden trinket flinched. “Yes, sir!”

“That goes for everyone!” Jack snapped. He had said that before! “Don't take anything here! First, you never know if it's trapped. Second, thanks to our magic scanner, we’ll find out anyway, and then you'll be in trouble.”

He turned around to watch the balcony for a moment and pretended not to hear the sounds of more trinkets being thrown into the closest crates. Soldiers were the same whatever their nationality or age. Send them into a palace, and they'll try to loot it.

After a bit, he turned back to watch them work again. Some idiot would still try to sneak something past the scanner, Jack was sure of it, but that was better than half the soldiers. He'd still feel better once all the gold stuff was safely stored on board a transport.

And, speaking of transports… He cocked his head when he heard the sound of a shuttle descending on the base, then quickly ran the numbers in his head. Yep, unless this was some unscheduled supply drop that no one had bothered to tell him about, this would be Hordak, ferried here by a frigate from the closest Stargate to help with the whole portal stuff.

Jack just hoped the clone wouldn't blow up the planet.

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 30th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Hello.”

“Science buddy!”

Adora wasn't jealous - or envious, or whatever. She shouldn't feel bad watching Entrapta’s face light up when Hordak entered the research station just because Catra was still missing.

But she did. She missed her lover. Dearly. And seeing others reunited with their loves didn't help. She reminded herself that Hordak was experienced with portals to other dimensions and should be able to deal with the problems they were having here and managed to smile somewhat honestly when she nodded at him. “Hello. Good to have you here.” Neutral. Professional.

“I came as soon as I heard,” Hordak said, nodding back.

“And we need you!” Entrapta said, voice slightly muffled since she was still hugging him, and her face was buried in his chest. “I missed you!”

“I see,” Hordak said in a bland tone, but Adora could see he was blushing slightly.

“Fascinating.” Beta had appeared, peering at the couple. “I was not aware that different species felt attracted to each other. Or that Horde clones actually felt attraction. None of the data we gathered during the war indicated any such inclinations.”

Entrapta frowned as she released Hordak - somewhat; one hair tendril stayed wrapped around his waist - and turned to face Beta. “You didn't really gather enough data then! Once freed from their mental conditioning by Horde Prime and given enough time to grow, the clones are just like everyone else!” She blinked and cocked her head to the side, scrunching her nose. “Which should have been expected since Horde Prime was an Asgard, kind of.”

Beta looked surprised for a moment. “But the Asgard have abandoned sexual reproduction long ago. Why would one of their offspring develop such instincts?”

“Well, Loki wanted to revert the damage the Asgard genetics had suffered, and so it makes sense that that also included the capability for sexual reproduction,” Entrapta replied.

“I see.” Beta nodded. “Although I think I should exchange data with Alpha to update my memory banks about the biological sciences. While not essential for my own research, biological

aspects could play an important role in the project, and Alpha should have the most advanced data on the subject."

"Yeah, that's just what we need - a network of mad scientist bots," Jack muttered next to Adora.

She winced a little. Jack wasn't exactly wrong - Alpha and, apparently, Beta had some slightly worrisome tendencies when it came to their research. Loki, too, of course. But calling them mad scientists was a bit much. They were more like Entrapta - sometimes, they went too far in the pursuit of their research because they didn't consider all the consequences, but not maliciously so. Of course, they were a bit worse at weighing the consequences than Entrapa was, but that was a work in progress.

So… "We can do that once we have recovered everyone," Adora said.

"Right!" Entrapta nodded and turned back to Hordak. "I sent you our data. Did you find anything?"

"I went over it during transit - I could have done more if the vessel had had a dedicated laboratory," Hordak replied. "Unfortunately, despite his heritage, Horde Prime did not deign to add such a functionality to his fleet."

"Yeah." Entrapta nodded. "We should design a science vessel. Or maybe a science module we can add to a frigate - if we replace a shuttle with it, it should fit into a hangar bay. Oh! A science shuttle! Every ship could carry one if it were needed! Maybe we could make them specialist science shuttles, one type each for all the various fields!"

Adora cleared her throat. Case in point, as Mermista would say. "That sounds like a project for later," she said.

"Ah, right." Entrapta nodded. "Saving people first, then pushing science!"

"Yes." Adora nodded firmly - just in case Beta might disagree.

*****

"...so I found no fundamental fault in your methodology and came to the same conclusion as you did after analysing your data: Someone is removing the test subjects faster than you're tracking them."

Samantha Carter nodded as Hordak finished his summary. Part of her was disappointed that Hordak hadn't found anything that would allow them to recover the missing people, but another part of her felt vindicated for not having overlooked a solution. "That leaves us with the problem of finding out where they have been taken," she said.

"Yes." He nodded. "And it is doubtful that not enhanced sensors and searching methods will be enough for that - we would have to search an entire dimension, potentially an alternate universe, for that."

"Light Hope managed to find and snatch Adora from our universe while Etheria was still in Despondos," Entrapta pointed out. "And we have all the technology she had access to, and then some more!"

"She did," Hordak conceded. "But she might not have been searching for Adora specifically but merely for anyone who matched her criteria."

"That still means she could search another universe for such an individual," Sam said.

"But we don't know what exactly she did to achieve that," Hordak retorted. "The data died with her. Although I consider it likely that she used She-Ra's magic to find her - She-Ra's power would have been seeking a worthy vessel, and as Mara's moving of Etheria to Despondos proves, She-Ra's power can cross dimensions."

"Well, we have Adora here!" Entrapta said.

“But she already has She-Ra's power,” Sam retorted.

“Well, yes. And she can wield it.” Entrapta beamed.

Oh. “You want her to use her power to track Catra?” Sam asked.

“Yes! If she restores magic to this world, she should have enough power to cause a portal into another dimension.”

Sam bit her lower lip. That could work… or it could cause a lot of damage to the world - and to reality itself. But were there viable alternatives?

Sam couldn't think of one. “We'll have to be very careful with this,” she said. “We'll only have one shot for this. We can't afford to miss.”

Entrapta nodded emphatically. “Right! Let's gather more data, science buddies!”

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Unknown Location, January 31st, 2000 (Earth Time)

A nice cell was still a cell. Catra was very aware of that. Most of the ‘guest room’ was cut off by the force fields, anyway. And from her spot, she could only see part of the sky outside - the angle to the window didn’t allow her to see the walls or the ground. If she didn’t know better, she would have assumed that this was by design, to prevent prisoners from gathering intel - or snipers to silence them.

But she knew it was mostly coincidence - she had asked Glimmer after the war was over. Bright Moon just wasn’t really used to holding prisoners. Catra’s Bright Moon and this Bright Moon seemed to share that.

Though this Bright Moon was far more ruthless than Catra’s. All of the Horde, the entire Fright Zone, gone?

She shivered. It was almost ironic that she had thought Glimmer was ruthless and brutal compared to Angella. This Angella… She closed her eyes and leaned back against the force field. Was this Catra's Angella? She didn't know. But did it matter? This Angella had perfectly inserted herself into this world despite knowing that she wasn't their Angella - she had said she wasn't native to this dimension, unlike the others. Had she even told them? Or was she pretending to be their Angella?

Pretending to be someone's mother - or lover - without telling them that the real person was still missing… Who would do such a thing? Well, Double Trouble would, of course, that piece of scum would find it amusing, but who else would be able to do that? Just thinking about talking to this Adora, or kissing, or having sex, pretending to be their Catra made Catra feel sick. Angella couldn't be doing that, could she? She was supposed to be that great Queen, all noble and self-sacrificing, a bit too protective, and a bit too afraid of losing people, but to lie to this Adora, to this Glimmer, and pretend to be their Angella?

Catra shook her head. She couldn't believe it. But she couldn't believe the Angella she had heard so much about would wipe out the entire Fright Zone with everyone inside and be proud of it.

And this person was now deciding Catra's fate - and had made no secret of her hatred for Catra. Damn.

Even worse, if this Angella was lying to everyone else here, she wouldn't want Catra to reveal that both of them were from another dimension. Certainly not to Glimmer, her 'daughter'.

Catra clenched her teeth and couldn't help looking at the windows. If this Angella wanted to keep this secret, the best way would be to silence Catra permanently without giving her the chance to tell anyone. Was that why she had visited last night without anyone with her? If Catra hadn't mentioned Micah, would Angella have killed her?

Too many knew about Catra - the entire Princess Alliance - to disappear her, but if Angella could pass for this dimensions' queen, framing someone else for her death or arranging an accident or suicide wouldn't be difficult.

And Catra was helpless to stop her. She couldn't escape this force field - not even her claws would cut it. But the floor? She looked down, hesitated a moment, then pulled the thick carpet up and stared at the stone below. Marble. Her claws could cut it - a quick test confirmed it. Depending on how thick the floor was, she could escape. At least to the floor below. And she knew Bright Moon - once she was out of the cell, she could flee. Not even Adora would be able to catch her if she had enough of a lead.

And they would be looking for the Catra they knew - a person Catra wasn't any more. They would be working from all the wrong assumptions. Evading them would be child's play.

So she could escape. Unless there was another force field below the stone. Even so, if the floor was thick enough, she might be able to squeeze through between both force fields if she removed the stone - like digging a tunnel. That would take longer, of course. Something best left for the night.

Of course, the question was: Did she want to escape in the first place? That would make it harder for Adora - her Adora - and the others to find her. And kind of sour relations with this Bright Moon. If they just imprisoned her, Catra could stand it. She had been a prisoner before. And Adora and the others wouldn't take too long to find her. Probably.

They haven't found Angella in years, a small voice whispered in the back of her mind.

That was different! She told herself. They couldn't replicate the portal - but they had surely taken the base with the weapon that had hit Catra. Entrapta, Bow and Sam would be able to use that to find Catra.

She just had to wait. Survive and wait. She could do that.

But if Angella wanted her dead…

Catra clenched her teeth. She wasn't going to let herself be killed here. Certainly not so Angella could keep lying to everyone.

Maybe she should just risk it. Better safe than sorry? She had received breakfast a bit ago, so she wouldn't get lunch for a few more hours. Plenty of time to cut through the floor. In a pinch, she could cover a hole with the carpet. So…

The door opened, and Catra hastily dropped the edge of the carpet and stood up to face whoever was entering.

It was Angella. And… Micah and Entrapta! Angella must have rushed to the island right after leaving Catra to have made it back with them so quickly.

Catra wet her lips and drew a deep breath. "I told you they were alive and on Beast Island." Then she nodded at Micah and weakly smiled at Entrapta. "Hello."

All three glared at her, and Catra winced. That wasn't how her Micah and Entrapta would have reacted. "I guess you were right about the portal's danger," she told Entrapta.

Instead of agreeing - or sneering at her - this Entrapta looked confused. "What do you mean?"

That was… Something was wrong here. "You warned me not to open it," she said.

"I did?" Entrapta cocked her head to the side.

Catra clenched her teeth. "That was why you were sent to Beast Island," she said, her stomach twisting with guilt at the memory.

"But… I was banished to Beast Island because I tried to sabotage the portal."

That wasn’t how it happened. But had that happened here? Had Entrapta gone further than in Catra’s dimension? Were there other differences?

She glanced at Angella. How was Angella able to fool everyone else if there were more such differences?

The woman scowled and turned away. “Let’s leave the prisoner. She will get her just punishment soon enough.”

“I’m not your Catra!” Catra snapped. Should she accuse Angella of not being their Angella? Would Angella kill her with witnesses here?

She hesitated, and then the door closed, and she was alone again.

*****

The Secret Base Part 6

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, January 31st, 2000 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill liked watching Carter work. Especially if she was so focused, she forgot that she was being watched - in a way, the tension and complete focus on the task emphasised everything about her. It made her more… honest. There was no room for her polite, professional act. Just her and the task.

And she looks hot when she…

He pushed the utterly unprofessional voice away and ignored it. Carter was a fine officer, and both of them were members of the United States Air Force, anyway. Chain of command or not.

He leaned back against the wall in the main lab of Beta and watched Carter work on the laptop she had connected to the crystal array thingie. She was a faster typist than anyone else he knew. Well, except for Entrapta, but having magic hair that could use half a dozen keyboards at the same time, as she was demonstrating right now, was cheating, in Jack's opinion.

"OK! If we extrapolate the data gathered with this setting, then we should be able to narrow down the specific frequencies resonating with the background of the target dimension. And based on that, we should be able to detect frequencies that differ in crucial patterns from that," Entrapta announced.

Jack looked at Carter and raised his eyebrows.

"We will be able to detect people who aren't native to the target dimension, sir," Carter explained.

Jack nodded. He had suspected that - he wasn't a dumb marine; he was Air Force - but it was best to check.

“So, you’ll be able to find Catra!” Adora leaned forward. She looked almost feverish - she hadn’t really rested enough since this whole mess had started, in Jack’s opinion. But good luck trying to tell her that when others - like Carter - were pushing all-nighters as well.

“In theory, yes. We still need to test it,” Bow cut in. “It’s not that easy.”

“It would be easy if we were dealing with an actual parallel universe - the beginning of entropic cascade failure would give off specific radiation that we could detect,” Carter added. “Although that’s only if that theory about entropic cascade failure is actually correct. Of course, Beta’s data supports that.”

“Ancient records mention such cases, yes.” Beta had popped up next to them, and Jack barely managed not to jerk. “That’s why we were using a specific transfer dimension as a target. The fact that the dimension is influenced and even formed by sapient minds guarantees that you will not meet a dimensional analogue, reducing the risk of fatal consequences related to dimensional travel. Of course, that is merely for research; the actual value of travelling to such dimensions is debatable. There are no resources to be extracted or knowledge to be gained since everything depends on someone imagining it.”

“Not a good spot to found new colonies, huh?” Jack asked.

“Exactly!” Beta smiled at him - he had to work on his sarcasm. “Nothing created in such a dimension could survive the return to our dimension - the central laws of nature work differently there. Even the simplest material gathered in such a place might suffer rapid entropic decay once introduced to a less metaphysically unstable universe.”

“Is that the kind of decay that makes it crumble to dust or go critical?” Jack asked.

The way Carter, Entrapta and Bow blinked and glanced at each other wasn't very comforting.

"That's an excellent question." Beta nodded approvingly in that condescending way of hers. "We should find out."

"Only under the strictest security, of course," Carter added.

Entrpata nodded in agreement, but Jack still didn't trust the glint in her eyes.

"No blowing up the planet by mistake!" he told them with a frown.

"Of course not!" Beta frowned at him in return. "That would threaten the research station itself and all our work!"

"And kill us all," Jack added in a flat voice.

"And prevent us from saving Catra and the others!" Adora glared at everyone. Or she was trying not to fall asleep - it was hard to tell.

"Right!" Entrapta nodded. "We'll have to do that in space then - and on the other side of the planet so any exotic radiation generated by such a decay won't affect the base."

"But first, we need to test our new sensors," Carter said, bringing everyone back on course.

"Yes!" Once more, hair tentacles flew out, and keyboards started to sound like automatic weapons.

Jac slightly shook his head. Before he could make a comment - or tell Adora to catch some sleep - his communicator vibrated, indicating someone wanted to talk to him. "Work calls," he said, leaving the lab to check who thought they had a problem only he could with this time.

Some people really needed to show more initiative. As long as they weren't researching potentially planet-wrecking

superweapons, of course.

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Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 1st, 2000 (Earth Time)

Taweret glared at them when Adora had Beta depolarise the force field that kept her locked up. She should have done this earlier, but between ensuring that her friends had everything that they needed to get Catra back and sorting out a few issues with the occupation of the planet, there hadn't been time for that. And Taweret had been safe and comfortable, sort of, in her cell anyway - not as comfortable as she was used to, of course, or if she would have been held in Bright Moon, but it wasn't as if she was in a Horde cell.

"Hello, Taweret," she said with a nod and a smile. "Hello, Zahra," she added for the host the Goa'uld was controlling. "I am She-Ra, Princess of Power." She gestured at the others. Taweret had already met them, but she might not remember them. "You already know General O'Neill and Sha're. These are Queen Glimmer of Bright Moon and Dr Jackson. And Jakar and his host Mats."

Taweret nodded curtly after standing up from her cot - she was still shorter than Adora but a bit taller than Glimmer, Adora noted. She didn't miss that the Goa'uld ignored the Tok'ra, either.

"I'm sorry it took a while to get around to you, but we were kind of busy taking over your bases and dealing with your ships," she said.

"I hope they accounted themselves well," Taweret said with a toothy smile.

"Not really," Jack drawled. "Paperwork was more challenging than your guards."

The Goa'uld sneered. "Apophis assured me that he sent his best warriors with me."

"Well, if they were his best, this would be a short war," Jack replied.

"You defeated one fleet of his. He has more. Many more," Taweret retorted. "More than enough to destroy the Tau'ri and your new allies."

"Ah." Daniel raised his finger. "That's a bold statement, but since you don't know how many forces our Alliance can field, it's just a boast."

The Goa'uld glared at him. "The Goa'uld Empire rules the galaxy, and Apophis is the most powerful of the System Lords. No force can stand against him. Certainly not the Tok'ra, who only survived by hiding in the shadows for millennia."

That sounded like empty bravado to Adora - the galaxy was far too large to be ruled by the Goa'uld. And Apophis wasn't the most powerful of the Goa'uld any more.

"And yet, you never dared to intrude into Horde Prime's territory - or challenge the Asgard," Sha're said.

Taweret tensed, glaring at her, then raised her chin and scoffed. "If either of those powers were allied with you, where are they? Do you expect me to believe that they would let their clients deal with me?"

"We might need to get a bigger cell for her ego," Jack muttered next to Adora.

She chuckled at that while she pushed the button on her communicator. "Hordak?"

A moment later, Hordak walked into the hallway facing Taweret's cell, and the Goa'uld queen recoiled, gaping.

She recovered quickly, though. “That’s not Horde Prime.”

“You are correct,” Hordak told her. “I am Hordak. The first of his clones to gain my freedom.”

“So, you’re a deserter.” Taweret laughed, though it sounded a bit forced. “What will you do once Horde Prime finds you?”

“Horde Prime is dead. I killed him,” Adora told her.

“An empty boast!” Taweret retorted with a sneer. “This is a farce! Will you claim to be a Gate Builder next?”

“It is the truth,” Adora said. “Horde Prime attacked our home and we defeated him - and freed his clones from his control. They joined our alliance.”

“You expect me to believe that?”

“Actually, no,” Jack said with a grin. “We don’t. But it makes telling you the truth more fun.”

Adora resisted the urge to roll her eyes at him. “We want you to understand your situation. And your options.”

Taweret narrowed her eyes. “You need my help. That’s why you are doing this… production! To impress and fool me!”

“We don’t actually need your help,” Adora said. “Beta already told us that you don’t know anything useful about the experiments here.”

“But you want my knowledge of Apophis’s court and his plans!” Taweret scoffed. “You expect me to betray him because of such a transparent lie!”

“We expect you to betray him to save your own skin,” Jack told her. “Or because you want to usurp him. Or just because. You’re a Goa’uld.”

“Cooperation is your only chance of survival,” Jakar spoke up using his Goa’uld voice, and Taweret flinched. “If you kill your host, you die. If you let yourself be removed from her without killing her, you’ll live.”

“Traitor!” Taweret hissed in return. “I know what you do to those you capture.”

“We would like to mete out the punishment you deserve, but our allies do not condone that,” Jakar replied with a glance at Adora.

She nodded. “Yes. We don’t kill prisoners. Cooperate, release your host, and we will guarantee your life.”

“You will meet Amaunet and the other Goa’uld prisoners who can confirm this,” Sha’re told her.

Adora tensed. If Taweret decided to kill her host… They could stun her, of course. If they were quick enough, they could keep her sedated until the Tok’ra could remove her. But it was dangerous. It was better to persuade her to cooperate.

“You made a lot of fantastic claims. Who are you?” Taweret was sneering again.

“I told you already - I am She-Ra, Princess of Power.”

“And I’m Glimmer, Queen of Bright Moon. We represent the Princess Alliance of Etheria.”

“That means nothing!”

“We defeated Horde Prime. We freed his clones. And we’re restoring magic to the galaxy,” Adora said.

Taweret gasped at the last part. Oh - of course! She was old enough to remember the time before the First Ones stole the magic from the sector for the Heart of Etheria.

Adora smiled at her. “We did that to Saqqara. You probably noticed that.” Well, they had been forced to, as a last resort, but she didn’t need to know that.

Taweret stared at her. “An empty boast!” she spat - but it sounded hollow.

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“Hordak! You're back! How was the talk with Taweret?”

Samantha Carter looked up at Entrapta's comment. Indeed, Hordak had returned.

“It went as expected. Without proof, Taweret did not believe our claims - or professed such doubt, at least. Although since she seemed unsettled at the end, I believe we had a conditional success,” he replied. “Whether it was worth my absence from our work, time will tell.”

Sam swallowed a comment about self-importance; Hordak had been absent for less than an hour, and while he was a great scientist, even double that time wouldn't make much of a difference, if any at all, in their search for a way to save Catra and the other missing people. They had to take longer breaks to eat and sleep, after all.

But provoking an argument would be wasting time and creating friction; Hordak was quite prickly. Not as bad as some of Sam's colleagues from Earth, but he wouldn't shrug off such a comment as easily as Entrapta or Bow.

So she focused back on her sensor analysis while Hordak returned to studying the remote projector's focusing crystals with Entrapta. Their last experiment had proven that their idea could work, but they needed to refine their approach to get the details needed to actually track non-natives in the other dimension by the changes they caused. And improving the sensors to that point not only required improved computing power, which they had acquired by

linking advanced machines from the lab and the fleet above, but also better algorithms.

And coding those, especially so they could run on a hodgepodge of different operating systems, was a challenge. Even for someone like Sam, who had a lot of experience linking First Ones, Horde and Earth technology thanks to her research with Entrapta.

A challenge she would beat, Sam reminded herself as she adjusted her code a bit more, then ran another test on the raw sensor data. If only she had a way to make the computers copy her own thoughts… She blinked. Maybe she needed a break if she was thinking about things like that.

The test would run a few minutes, anyway, producing thousands of individual analyses and compiling them into one data set so she wouldn't waste time either way. "I'll be right back," she announced before leaving the room.

When she entered the secondary control room serving as a break room, the huge holoscreen there was showing a comedy from Earth - Entrapta had linked it to the spy bot network so they could get a feed from Earth. The lag was bad, but that didn't matter when you were merely watching media instead of communicating.

Sam used the remote on the table - like the rest of the furniture, it was from the expeditionary force meant for a field headquarters and looked a little out of place in the room - to switch channels. No one else was present, and she preferred the news over some sappy Hollywood movie. Especially if it was a sappy Hollywood movie featuring a scientist in too-tight clothes flirting with a dashing military officer and a plot with holes large enough to fly a frigate through. At least there was no love triangle with an alien this time.

"...and despite the mounting pressure for transparency, Alliance Command insists that they cannot reveal the files from Stargate Command for military reasons. So, fact-checking claims remains a

challenge, which is why we have invited two experts to the studio to discuss this."

Sam closed her eyes and sighed. She was tempted to switch channels again, but it would be useful to keep up with Stargate Command's media reputation in the public. Getting blindsided once by rumours about a - completely fictional, thank you - near-catastrophe featuring black hole research had been bad enough.

So she sipped coffee and nibbled on a pastry while watching two 'experts' discussing her former team.

"...and while there was a civilian on the team, that doesn't change the fact that it was a military team, led by an officer, and part of a military operation. That will have coloured their interaction with the galaxy at large. A civilian team would have reacted quite differently to alien cultures."

"But that is understandable since we were already at war with the Goa'uld. You have to consider military necessity in such a situation."

"The war was started by a clandestine program of the United States Air Force, funded from black accounts, without more than perfunctory oversight, and focused on developing advanced alien superweapons."

"To defend Earth."

"If it had been about defending Earth, Stargate Command would have recruited the best and brightest scientists for their research, regardless of their nationality. But they stuck to the military instead."

"Samantha Carter is amongst the world's foremost physicians."

"And a Major in the Air Force. That has far more weight than…"

Sam sighed. In a way, it was ironic that after years of having to struggle against the perception that she owed her commission to

her scientific expertise and wasn't a 'real officer' despite having more combat experience than most of her peers, now people were using her military rank to disparage her scientific credentials. Although it was hardly surprising - some of her colleagues in the field had massive yet very vulnerable egos and would latch onto any excuse for their lack of success in research. At least the experts hadn't claimed that she had slept her way to the top here.

"...and rumours of her close relationship to Princess Entrapta remain in light of Etheria's known stance on such things and…"

Sam clenched her teeth. That should teach her to taunt Murphy. She shook her head and left the room. The test should be finished by now, and if the results matched projections, they should be ready for another experiment soon.

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Unknown Location, February 1st, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra eyed the door and held her breath, ears twisting. She couldn't hear anything or anyone outside. Of course, the doors were thick - she knew that from her Bright Moon - and so that didn't mean the coast was actually clear.

She clenched her teeth. She couldn't wait any longer. This Bright Moon was too different, this Angella too messed up and dangerous, for Catra to risk waiting any longer in the hope that her friends would find and save her. At any moment, Angella could decide that Catra had to die. Either for her past crimes or to keep her from telling everyone that Angella was not this dimension's Angella. Or both.

Catra had to save herself.

She resisted the urge to look once more for hidden cameras observing her - she couldn't do anything about them, anyway - and lifted the carpet, revealing the lightly scratched stone floor below. "Here goes nothing…" she whispered as she unsheathed her claws, then slashed down.

It took a bit more swipes and slashes to cut through the stone than she had expected, but it was fast work, and she soon had the stone cut and broken into pieces she could easily lift out of the growing hole.

And then her claws cut through stone and found nothing - not a force field painfully stopping her swipe, but empty air. She grinned, dug the claws of one hand into the stone and cut around it with her other hand, then lifted with a grunt.

A hole. Not yet large enough to fit through, but she could see the floor below her in the soft light of the moons that shone through the windows. Perfect! Now she just had to…

Her ears twitched as she not only heard a waterfall but also breathing, and her eyes widened. That wasn't an empty room below - someone was sleeping there! Damn! In her Bright Moon, those rooms weren't occupied!

She dropped the stone on the floor of her cell, next to the other pieces - no sense in trying to hide them - and quickly enlarged the hole by cutting off another piece. She could squeeze through now, though it would be a tight fit. Better widen it some more.

Then she was done. Taking a deep breath, she laid down on the floor, frowning at the dust covering the carpet and getting into her fur, and pushed her head through the hole to take a peek.

There, at the wall, was the waterfall she had heard. There was also a big window facing East, a balcony to the south, vanity and armoires, a half-open door leading to a huge bathroom, and a massive canopy bed in the off-centre that looked vaguely familiar. This was a guest room, and a first-class one.

She held her breath and looked around for a sword. If this was Adora's room… No. No sword. But she saw a trident peeking out from under the bed and had to swallow a curse.

This was Mermista's room! She cocked her head and eyed the bed, whose occupant was hidden by the curtains. She didn't hear

two breaths and saw no clothing strewn around the room, so Mermista hadn't been busy with Sea Hawk and was now exhausted and sleeping deeply.

Well, that wouldn't stop Catra. She could sneak past an alert awake Mermista; a sleeping one was child's play. Baring her teeth, she pushed headfirst through the hole and dug her claws into the ceiling below before swinging through and letting go, landing on all fours on the thick carpet in the middle of the room with barely a sound.

Perfect!

She grinned as she moved past the bed towards the balcony. She could easily climb down from there to the yard below - she knew that from experience. It was a little hard on the wall there, but Catra didn't give a damn about this Bright Moon's appearance.

She brushed the curtain half-covering the door to the balcony aside and slipped out, peering down at the yard. Yeah, she recognised the location. From here, she could easily slip out of the palace, and then she had multiple routes to the fields surrounding the town. If she went all-out, she could reach the whispering forest before the sun rose and anyone would notice her absence. So, she just…

Something was moving down there! Hissing under her breath, she moved back and ducked, waiting for an alarm to be raised, ready to scramble down the wall and fight her way out.

But instead of yelling, she heard a grunt, followed by something flying over the balcony's railing and hitting the floor next to her with a thud.

A grappling hook? She stared at it, blinking, while it was pulled back, then got hooked over the railing. Who would…? She closed her eyes and stifled a groan when she realised who would scale the wall like this.

“Oh, my love, I'm coming!”

Yeah, the whisper confirmed it. Sea Hawk was visiting Mermista at night. Judging by the slightly slurred words, he probably carried a rose between his teeth.

Catra glanced back. She could hide - perhaps under the bed - and just let him and Mermista get it on, then sneak out and climb down. But if either Sea Hawk or Mermista spotted the hole in the ceiling…

And hiding under a bed while two people had sex on it wasn't exactly how Catra wanted to spend her time, either. Not with her sensitive ears and nose.

Screw it! She moved back, then dashed behind the curtain at the door, her back to the wall, and peered through the small gap facing the doorframe.

“Oh, my dear Mermista! Your love is coming!”

Catra saw a hand grip the railing and heard a grunt. Then Sea Hawk pulled himself up and swung his legs over it. And he really was holding a rose between his teeth! Catra resisted the urge to shake her head and held her breath while he straightened, then walked into the room.

Now!

As soon as he was past her, she slipped out behind his back, vanishing around the corner.

“My Love! I've climbed mountains to reach you!”

“Ugh… What the…? You're late!”

Catra shook her head and ignored the couple's greeting as she gripped the rope dangling from the grappling hook and started to climb down. At least they seemed distracted, so she would…

“Look at the ceiling! Sea Hawk!”

“My love!”

“Not that - the ceiling! Someone broke into the room! That's… the prisoner! She escaped!”

Damn! Catra clenched her teeth and dropped the rest of the way down, then started to run.

Catra's Mermista was loud enough ‘to be heard through a hurricane’, as Sea Hawk had once described it at an Alliance dinner, and this Mermista was no exception. Catra knew the palace guards would be on alert in moments. Her original escape plan would need to be adjusted - she couldn't count on sneaking out into the town. Not with the palace lighting up as guards - and soon princesses - started looking for her.

She changed course and headed to the corner of the yard, running straight at the wall to the outer part of the palace, dropping down to all fours to pick up speed. One, two… She launched herself into the air and hit the upper part of the wall with her claws extended, shredding the surface as she scrambled the last few yards up.

She slid over its top, trying to flatten herself to minimise her silhouette to anyone looking her way, and dropped down on the other side. She tore up the lawn as she landed, but that couldn't be helped. Though she could use that to lay a false track.

She tore off, claws ripping chunks of earth and grass, towards the gate to the side, but changed direction as soon as she hit the stone-plated path that led through this ornamental yard. Let the guards think she still wanted to escape to the town.

But her real destination was the back of the palace. She moved a bit slower, without her claws granting her traction at high speed, and vanished between two rows of bushes with fancy flowers, then ducked under a fence and dashed past an empty stable - had this Glimmer also had a pony in the palace once? It seemed like it.

And the original Angella hadn't skimped on pasture for the poor pony either - the fence reached all the way to the outer wall of the palace. It was high enough to shield the entire princess playground from view and would do the same for Catra now.

Until she went over it, of course. She could scale it easily using her claws, but if anyone spotted the traces that would leave before she could get away from the palace, she would likely be caught halfway down the cliff on the other side…

She should have taken Sea Hawk's grappling hook and rope with her. Hissing at her mistake, she eyed the wall, then the tree next to it. It had been carefully trimmed by the palace gardener into a decoration, but it was still tall enough to reach halfway to the wall's top. It would have to do.

And while climbing the tree, she would be covered from view by the foliage. She quickly went up, weaving around the many branches, until she reached the top, which was slightly swaying under her weight.

Glancing back, she could see the palace fully alert - all the lights were on, and she could hear more shouting and yelling and see movement behind windows. Yeah, operation 'Catch the Cat' was in full swing.

But Catra hadn't almost beaten the entire Alliance through dumb luck. Scoffing, she shifted her weight, causing the treetop to sway even more. Back and forth, back and forth, back and… She jumped, holding her breath, reaching out as she stretched her body. Her fingertips clamped down on the edge of the top of the wall, and she clenched her teeth as she resisted the urge to unsheathe her claws and get a better grip.

Instead, she pulled herself up, shifting grips to find better purchase on top, and swung her legs over the wall, followed by her body until she was hanging by her fingertips on the other side - straight above the cliff overlooking Bright Moon's lake.

Exactly where she wanted to be right now, she reminded herself. If not for long.

On this side, she had no choice and had to use her claws to descend; the wall ended where the cliff began, and there was no ledge to drop down on. If she fell, she would bounce off the cliff a few times until she hit the water at terminal velocity, as Entrapta would say.

She wouldn't fall. Digging her claws into the wall, she let go of the top and started her descent.

She clenched her teeth at the sound her claws made as they slowed her down until she hit the base of the wall. If anyone heard that… But she was committed now.

The cliff itself was steep but far from smooth, so she had to start climbing down instead of sliding. That slowed her down some. She still made a good pace - thanks to her claws, she could make her own hand- and footholds.

But when she was still halfway to the ground below, she heard a familiar and thoroughly unwelcome sound: Flapping wings. Large wings. A quick glance around confirmed her fear: Adora was riding Swift Wind - and headed to the cliff.

Catra looked down. She was still too far up to risk jumping into the water below her. Going up was out of the question. And she was too exposed on the cliff to hide.

Damn.

Maybe if she hid herself in a crook in the cliff, Adora might miss her in the dim moonlight. But where was such a spot? Pressed against the stone, Catra had trouble seeing a good hiding spot. And if she moved, she would draw more attention to herself.

She muttered another curse. Move and hope to find a hiding spot before Adora found her? Or stay still and hope Adora missed her

in the middle of the cliff? No, this Adora wasn't her Adora, but she was likely as stubborn - or more so.

Catra slowed down a little bit, though, and tried to keep an eye on Adora. If she moved smoothly and not too quickly, and timed her faster movement to the moments when Adora wasn't looking in her direction, she might escape notice.

Adora swept past her - and above her. She was starting her search from the top, then. Not the bottom, to cut off any escape. Did she know Catra hadn't had time to reach the bottom yet? Or was that because Adora wanted to be able to swoop down once she found Catra instead of having to climb up?

It didn't matter why, just that she did. Catra clenched her teeth and kept climbing down. There! That might be a hiding spot - a small gap between a protruding rock and another, just large enough for her to fit in.

Baring her fangs in a grim smile, Catra started making her way to the spot. A glance up confirmed that Adora, while closing in, was still about two passes away from her height. That should be enough time to slip around the rock in the way and hide.

She held her breath as she waited, in the barely-there shadow of the rock, for Adora to pass above her. Almost. Almost. Now! Swift Wind swept past, and Catra pushed off, claws digging into the hard rock as she traversed the rock as fast as she could. She only had a second or two… She panted for breath when she slid into the narrow gap, pressing herself against the stone. Now she had to wait until Adora passed this spot, then wait some more until they finished here and went away to search the stables or something. Then Catra could finish her descent and disappear into the forest below.

Her ears twitched - Swift Wind was approaching. Catra resisted the sudden urge to turn and face the rock, not looking until she heard the flying horse pull away. She had to see what was happening. She wouldn't cower like that.

So she watched Adora fly towards her. It wasn't her Adora, but it was a beautiful sight anyway - Adora's outfit shone in the moonlight. Almost ethereal. Even Swiftwind didn't distract from it - his white fur and wings caught the light as well.

Then the two were past, and Catra sighed with relief. That was… She froze. Adora was turning early - and coming back. Had she…?

She must have - she was coming straight at Catra! Damn. Catra looked around. Still too high to jump. Hell, she was so high, if she jumped, Adora could easily catch her before she hit the… Catra's eyes widened. It was a foolish idea. Stupid. But… even if this Adora wasn't her Adora, she couldn't be completely different from her Adora, could she? Not if things had happened more or less like in Catra's dimension.

It was the best shot she had. If she was recaptured, she would be put in a cell from which she couldn't escape. Or killed.

So she pushed herself out of the gap, only holding on to the rock with one foot and one hand, and turned to face Adora. Familiar eyes widened with surprise before they narrowed again.

Smiling, Catra closed her eyes and jumped.

"CATRA!"

She didn't open her eyes and let her body go limp as she fell, the wind tearing at her as she picked up speed. If she had misjudged this Adora…

"CATRA!"

Closer. And she sounded a bit concerned. Catra's smile widened a little, though she kept her eyes squeezed shut. Yes!

Then, an arm wrapped around her waist, fingers digging into her side, and she was pulled into Adora's side. A moment later, her stomach lurched as Swift Wind started to pull out of his dive.

“You idiot!” she heard Adora yell as they slowed down and levelled out. “Trying to kill herself?”

“Without wings, you cannot fly,” Swift Wind commented.

And now they were above the lake at the foot of the cliff. Far above it - but not so far that a fall would be fatal.

Catra twisted in Adora’s grip, turning her head to face her. “I’m sorry about this,” she said, smiling.

Adora’s expression darkened. “Oh, you will be…”

Catra wriggled - her arms were caught by Adora, but she was flexible, and Adora was so close… She twisted, then leaned forward and cut Adora off with a kiss.

And when Adora froze, gasping with shock and surprise, her grip loosening, Catra bent her knees, brought her feet up, and jumped out of her grip, diving for the lake below.

This time, Adora wasn’t quick enough to catch her before she hit the water.

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Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

“...and while the actions of SG-1 are undoubtedly heroic, one has to consider the situation during which they were taken: They were active during a war that only started because the United States government tampered with an alien relic in secret.”

“I'm not sure it’s ‘heroic’ to visit another planet with a group of soldiers and a nuclear bomb in tow and then blow up the government there when they take exception to that, Jim.”

“It was an expedition to another planet - of course, they had to be prepared for the worst. Matter of fact, the worst case

happened, and they dealt with it, Frank!"

"And they weren't all soldiers - Dr Jackson was with them."

"He was in uniform!"

"But he's a civilian!"

"That's a technicality. He looked the same as the soldiers. And during his time with SG-1, he was armed and fighting like any other member of SG-1."

"But he was still a civilian!"

"As much a civilian as any other private military contractor!"

Jack O'Neill turned to Daniel, who was staring at the screen with his mouth hanging open. "Did they just call you a mercenary?"

"They… they did! But that's preposterous! I am a consultant!" Daniel shook his head. "A scientist!"

Jack grinned. "Well, you have taken part in pretty much every battle we've been involved in. And you did get combat pay, didn't you?"

"I didn't get combat pay!" Daniel protested. "That's reserved for members of the Armed Forces. My recompensation was just adjusted for hazardous duties."

"Potato, potato," Jack retorted, still grinning. "The media thinks you were a mercenary."

"That's not the media! That's just the most extreme bunch of pundits they could throw together for a cheap rating boost!" Daniel shook his head. "Why are we watching this.. this sensationalist drivel?"

"Because Carter wanted to know what people back on Earth were saying about us," Jack replied as he grabbed another soda from

the cooler they had installed in Beta's new break room. Not that Daniel was wrong - this talk show was more 'Jerry Springer' than anything else.

"...and all that still doesn't make SG-1 any less heroic! They've saved Earth from alien invasions long before the princesses arrived, Robert!"

"As part of the United States Armed Forces! They aren't some… some superhero team operating outside the law!"

"Stargate Command was operating outside the law!"

"It was not! The operation was covered by regulations."

"Regulations that obviously need heavy revisions!"

"You want to hamstring our military in the middle of a war?"

"Accountability for the military is most needed in the middle of a war! That's when rules and laws are in danger of being ignored in the name of expediency!"

Jack nodded. The guy was a genuine frothing-at-the-mouth lunatic, but he was right about that. Pretty much only about that, though. At least, even here, the majority of the 'experts' seemed to have a pretty positive view of SG-1, so…

"Or in the name of love. We've all heard the rumours about what SG-1 did when operating on alien planets."

"Oh, yes."

"Are you serious? We are talking about Stargate Command, not a Hollywood romance!"

"Dr Jackson brought a war bride home from the very first mission!"

Scratch that thought! Jack pressed his lips together. He glanced at his friend. Daniel was glaring at the screen. Probably not a good time to ask whether Sha're got a green card yet through their marriage. Though Jack better checked up on that before some bureaucrat with delusions of importance tried to make a fuss. He'd have one of his staff look into that.

"So much for the rally behind the flag effect," Daniel muttered as the pundits descended into another loud argument about the legality of Stargate Command and its actions in the past.

"For most people, it hasn't really sunk in that we're at war. We don't have a lot of casualties, and all the battles are fought off-world, without press coverage. So…" Jack shrugged.

"So *that*," Daniel said, nodding at the screen again. "Let's change the channel. I don't want to watch this any longer."

"Alright." Jack reached for the remote when the door opened, and Glimmer stuck her head inside. "There you are! We're about to start the experiment!"

Right. Jack got up. He wasn't going to miss that. If only to make sure Adora didn't try again to volunteer herself as a test subject. They couldn't risk her with the first experiment. They couldn't risk her with the second or third experiment, either, but Jack had a feeling that Adora wouldn't let that stop her if the first experiment succeeded.

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The Lost Dimension Part 1

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Finally! This had taken much too long! Adora bit her lower lip so she wouldn't say that out loud. She knew her friends were doing their best, and she also knew that dangerous experiments shouldn't be rushed. Even more so if it involved dimensional travel, which was extremely dangerous, and not just for the ones doing the experiments.

But knowing this didn't make waiting for her friends to find a way to save Catra any less stressful. Catra was lost in another dimension - a dimension they didn't know anything about except that it was shaped by people's thoughts and feelings, which didn't sound very safe at all. What if it reacted badly to Catra? Adora knew that her love still had some issues - despite Adora and her friends' help. What about all the other poor people who had been sent there by Beta on Taweret's orders?

The sooner they could go and get Catra and the rest back, the better!

Now, if only her friends would hurry up - *safely* hurry up, of course, without rushing things. Just… put a move on, or something.

"You didn't start without us, did you?"

Adora turned and refrained from glaring at Jack. Even though his joke was terrible.

"We're still running our last set of checks, sir," Sam told him. "Then we can use the projector to open a dimensional portal to the target dimension and send Atak through."

Adora felt a pang of guilt. She should be going through the portal, not Atak. Catra was her love - and this was her responsibility; she

was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance. And she was She-Ra, Princess of Power - out of everyone here, she was the hardest to kill.

But Entrapta, Sam and Bow had told her that She-Ra's power would add another variable to the experiment that might throw off their calculations. Even when she entered as Adora - she had asked. Well, they were the experts. They and Hordak, who hadn't said anything - he had scoffed, though, in his grumpy manner.

She looked at Atak, standing inside a yellow-painted round area in the centre of the room. He bowed his head as soon as he noticed her, and she struggled not to wince. He was risking his life for Catra; the least she could do was to show support and trust. At least he was well-prepared for this. He was wearing a space suit Entrapta had modified for him and was loaded down with all kinds of sensors - he looked like he had a spy bot strapped to his back. And a line was tethering him to a hook in the testing room. It would likely snap when the portal opened, but it might hold. Either way, they would get more data, Entrapta had said. Probably in case they had to lasso Catra and drag her back through the portal or something.

"Good, good." Jack nodded and walked over to Adora. "Don't worry, we've got this in hand." He smiled, but Adora couldn't help feeling that he might not be entirely honest. If this were easy, they would have done it already.

"The probability of success has been greatly increased compared to our last test," Beta said. It wasn't nearly as reassuring as she probably thought.

Adora nodded and smiled anyway. "I know."

"Alright!" Entrapta looked up from her tool. "Everything checks out! We're ready!"

And everyone turned to Adora.

She took a deep breath and nodded. "Let's start."

“Yes!”

Entrapta moved over to the main console, where Sam, Bow and Hordak were already seated.

“Charging up the primary and secondary power banks,” Sam said.

“Projector crystals aligned with the target solution,” Bow added.

“Shielding within expected parameters.” Beta, of course, wasn’t looking at any screen - they were inside her body, so to speak.

“Dimensional sensors tracking.” Hordak sounded almost bored. Wasn’t he nervous at all? The last time he had dabbled with dimensional travel, they had almost destroyed Etheria.

“Sensor lock achieved! Opening portal!” Entrapta yelled as her hair tendrils flew over two different consoles. “Stay away from the marked transport zone!”

Adora clenched her teeth as a humming noise filled the room. A moment later, Atak vanished, and the line that had been connected to his suit fell down - cut right above the edge of the affected area.

“Sensors working… searching,” Hordak announced. Still sounding bored.

“Secondary power banks active.”

Adora drew a short breath through her teeth. The longer this took, the bigger the risk of losing Atak was. And then they would…

“Target locked.”

Yes!

“Target solution generated. Crystals aligning.”

“Power banks ready.”

Come on! Adora silently urged her friends on.

“Opening Portal!”

Once again, the humming noise came - but it sounded slightly different. Or that was just Adora.

And Atak reappeared in the marked transport zone - and promptly fell down since he had appeared about two feet above the floor. But he had made it back! They could get people back from the other dimension!

Now they just had to find Catra!

*****

“What do you mean, you can’t find Catra?”

Samantha Carter winced a little - Adora was loud. “We can’t track Catra, so we can’t open a portal to her,” she repeated herself.

“But… You have her scans! All her data!” Adora protested.

Sam nodded. “But that’s not enough to track her in the other dimension.”

“We can track the effects non-natives - those transported there from here - have on the dimension,” Entrapta cut in. “But we can’t track individuals. Well, we can track individual signals, but we don’t know who they are. Our sensors aren’t able to track their biological data.”

“We managed to retrieve Atak because we knew exactly where he was since we sent him there,” Bow added.

Adora frowned at each of them. “But we have all the data from the experiments!”

Sam pressed her lips together. They had gone over that before. “Yes, we do - but we know that they moved after arriving there.”

Or had been moved.

"Then can't you reconstruct their, ah, routes?" Adora looked almost desperate.

"Well… we weren't tracking them afterwards, so we kinda lost their trace. So, we can't really tie the effects we can track to anyone specific," Entrapta said. "Sorry, but that data was never recorded - quite a mistake on Taweret's part."

And on Beta's, Sam added silently. Although with Beta's attitude toward the 'test subjects', one couldn't be sure that it had been a mistake or just indifference. Sam wasn't quite convinced that Beta had been 'just following orders' - the artificial intelligence had proven to be quite flexible in how she interpreted her orders.

As if she had read Sam's thoughts, Beta's holoprojection appeared next to them. "Unfortunately, Taweret was only interested in our research's potential as a weapon despite the obvious alternative uses dimensional travel offers."

Alternative but dubious uses. Indeed, contacting alternate universes to gather information - or resources - sounded tempting, and some Stargate Command analysts and scientists had proposed that after the incident with the Quantum Mirror, but they obviously hadn't considered the risk any such venture would carry. Even if they found a way to travel to alternate dimensions without destabilising their own, they would have to deal with the reactions of the natives of that dimension. The General had commented about Star Trek's mirror universe, but Sam knew that such extreme examples were not the only potentially hostile results of dimension travel. Not by far. The Alliance certainly would react a little concerned if other dimensions started to mine their worlds.

Not to mention that the only dimension they had been able to reach so far was a very unstable dimension instead of an alternate universe. Beta insisted that it was merely a transitory choice, a way to travel to actual parallel dimensions - or higher planes of

existence, though the Artificial Intelligence had been a bit quiet about the original aim of the research station since the Alliance had taken over.

“Then we can just open a portal to everyone we find!” Adora blurted out. “We need to find everyone anyway!”

Sam winced. This was possible, of course - a simple brute-force solution. But it wasn't advisable, in her opinion, at least. “We would have to do that blindly - we would target anyone fitting the target data and then forcefully transport them to our dimension without knowing their identity - or willingness to be transported - until after the fact.” That would be kidnapping people.

Adora bit her lower lip. “But…” She trailed off.

“Also, each such portal will affect the target dimension and make it harder to track the changes from others. The bleed-through from the portal is vastly stronger than the effects from individuals after the fact,” Entrapta added. “And the effects of She-Ra's power might amplify that.”

Sam nodded. “And we already cannot track everyone who's missing.” Of course, some of them could have died - that would explain the missing number.

“Worst case, we'll completely lose track of people,” Bow added. “It's already hard to track some of them.”

Sam was aware of that. “It might be related to how foreign they feel, which would depend on their respective environments. If they don't feel out of place, they might not cause a lot of changes.” Or any at all.

“Whatever! But you can track people we send over, right?” Adora asked.

“Yes.” Sam nodded. It wouldn’t be easy either, but they would be able to reliably track anyone they transported to the other

dimension. As long as nothing went wrong with their sensors or computers.

“So, we can send a search party to the other dimension!” Adora smiled. “One portal, that should be manageable. And when we find Catra and the others, we open the next portal.”

“Oh, yes! We can do that!” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. “Though we'll have to find a way to communicate.”

“After a few more tests,” Sam quickly added. “We still don’t know how the entire process and the target dimension are affected by magic.”

“Yes,” Bow agreed. “We don’t want to mess this up and lose any more people, right?”

“Of course not.” Adora nodded, though it was obvious that she wanted nothing more than going to look for Catra right this moment. “How long will that take?”

Sam took a deep breath. “It will take a few more experiments. We need to test the process with magitech first and then scale it up.”

“Working up to She-Ra,” Bow said.

“We’re not going to test this with princesses or sorceresses,” Adora said, narrowing her eyes. “When we reach that point, I’ll be going through.”

“Of course.” Bow smiled weakly, though Sam understood - she knew Adora well; her friend wouldn’t budge on that.

“OK!” Entrapta beamed, of course. “We’ll run a series of tests - we should have most magitech devices for testing available.”

“And I will gladly carry them for you, Goddess,” Atak said.

“You don’t have to, Atak!” Adora said at once.

“It is my honour to help you, Goddess.” Atak bowed his head.

“And since you have no potential for magic, you won’t affect the readings!” Entrapta nodded.

“And we kind of need a sapient tester to retrieve them,” Bow added before Adora could object. “Otherwise, we can’t retrieve them.”

Adora grimaced and almost pouted but agreed - after a moment.

And Sam softly sighed with relief. They really couldn’t rush this. Though they couldn’t take too long, either, if what she suspected was true - the data potentially showed that the effect of non-natives on the target faded faster than expected. If the dimension or the intruders adapted to each other, then they would lose the ability to track the missing people - and the search team they apparently would be sending through. And they still had to find a way to communicate with anyone they sent over - a search party wouldn't be of much use when they couldn't tell the research station when to take them back.

Fortunately, Sam and the others had a few ideas about that.

*****

Unknown Location, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra really didn't like the Whispering Woods. For years, the stupid forest had been a thorn in her side. It had shielded Bright Moon from the Horde’s advances. Scouting parties regularly vanished without a trace - and not just because of Alliance ambushes. Catra had checked after the war. Armoured thrusts ran into bogs and terrain so rough and dense, even hovertanks had trouble advancing any further - and any column stuck in the woods just became easy prey for flanking attacks by Alliance forces. Or for some of the nastier monsters hiding in the cursed forest.

But right now, she loved the Whispering Woods. If not for them, she would have been recaptured already. Just getting away from this dimension's Adora had been tricky. If she had decided to fetch Mermista at once, instead of searching for Catra herself at first, Catra wouldn't have managed to leave the lake she had fallen in before Salineas's princess turned it inside out.

Hell, the river Catra had been swimming inside had flown backwards for a few minutes. If she hadn't managed to grab a root at the riverbank and pull herself out, she would have been carried back to the lake.

But Catra had escaped. The lake, the river, and the manhunt in the fields that followed - Jack better certified her for passing SERE training after this - evading half the Princess Alliance's army was like the final test from hell, even if most of the princesses hadn't shown up in time to do anything.

Of course, if Bright Moon's farms had been a little bigger, with fewer hedges and small patches of woods separating them and little creeks leading from the woods to the river, Catra wouldn't have managed it. Not with Adora on Swift Wind flying overhead.

Whatever. She had made it into the woods. Now she just had to survive until Adora - her Adora - showed up with the rest of their friends. She froze for a moment, one hand on a huge tree trunk that had fallen over and barred her way. How could they find her? Catra didn't have her communicator any more. And she was currently in the middle - well, on her way to the middle - of the Whispering Woods precisely because not even the entire Alliance army would be able to find her here.

She muttered a curse under her breath as she climbed over the trunk - without using her claws; best not leave any tracks this dimension's Bow could find. How could her friends find her? She hadn't thought about that when she escaped. Not that she had had a choice. If she had stayed, she would have been at the dubious mercy of Angella.

Should she turn around and head to the edge of the woods? No. She would just make it easier for her pursuers. And without a communicator, she wouldn't be able to tell if her friends had arrived until she saw her Adora as She-Ra.

But if she just hid in the woods, no one would be able to find her. Not even her friends. Of course, if her friends found this dimension's princess Alliance first, Catra might not have to go to the edge of the Whispering Woods to hear the explosions.

Wait! Catra tensed. This Adora had found her very quickly - relatively quickly - after she had arrived in this dimension. So, there was a way to track people!

She looked over her shoulder. And if they used that, they could find her here. Only… it had been hours now since her escape. The sun was up. If they could track her like that, wouldn't they have done so already? Adora could travel the Whispering Woods without a care; nothing there could really hurt She-Ra. Hell, Light Hope's base had been in the Whispering Woods, and Adora had visited regularly.

Catra sighed. No, however they had managed to track her before - probably by tracking the dimensional transport - they couldn't use it on her now. She was safe!

Then she heard a clicking noise, followed by the sound of breaking wood and rustling leaves. Something big was pushing through the underwood. And it didn't sound like a Horde Hauler - those were legs she heard. Many legs.

She flashed her fangs. She could take any monster here in the woods. And she could use the stress relief. On the other hand, any pursuit might find the monster's carcass, and it wouldn't take a genius to figure out who had killed it once they saw the claw marks.

Damn! She clenched her teeth and started to move away from the approaching creature. A little detour sounded like the best choice.

Not that she knew where exactly she was going, anyway.

But as she climbed over a few more fallen tree trunks, the noise of the monster behind her didn't fade. The thing was tracking her! And probably leaving a trail even Kyle could follow.

No choice, then - the stupid thing, whatever it was, had to die. She just had to make sure she wouldn’t leave an easy track to follow afterwards.

Catra bared her teeth and looked around, checking the trees - there! She quickly dashed over to the tallest, sturdiest trunk she could see and launched herself up, reaching for the lowest branch. A quick grab, swing and a series of jumps later, she was crouching on a thick branch and staring in the direction of the approaching monster.

The trees shook in the thing's wake, birds lifting off in swarms and ripped foliage carried away by a breeze, but she didn't see many trees being toppled - just a few smaller ones. Then, she spotted part of an armoured shell through the gaps in the canopy. Ah - a giant bug.

That was annoying. Even with her claws, it was hard to get through their shells, and they took a lot of damage to finish off. On the other hand, that made for a very good stress relief - she could go all-out.

Although… why was the thing tracking her? The bugs generally didn't do that back home. They tried to eat you if they found you, and they chased you if you tried to run, but they didn’t follow you through half the woods for so long - not without having attacked you before, at least.

She shook her head and focused on the fight at hand when the bug broke through another large bush and stopped, antennas twitching as the head slowly turned and rose to look at Catra.

Catra hissed at it, and the bug clicked its mandibles in return - and charged at her.

The tree on which she was crouching was probably large enough to withstand the bug's attack, but Catra wasn't going to find out the hard way if she was correct. She raced forward on the branch, claws tearing up the bark, then pounced on the monster with a yell.

The thing dug its legs in and reared, leaving furrows in its wake, but it was too slow and too late - Catra hit its body, claws slicing into the shell as she slid down its side, before it finished raising its front legs.

And as it turned, trying to bite her, Catra slid underneath it and slashed at the thing's softer belly. The shell wasn't as thick and hard here as on top, and Catra's claws left behind cuts that bled ichor.

The thing roared and turned around itself, legs ripping up the earth as it tried to hit her. Catra hissed again as she dodged the closest leg, then lashed out at the joints, another weak point. A few frantic swipes later, the lower part of the leg crashed to the ground, and the monster cried out even louder.

But it had a dozen more limbs, all trying to crush Catra underneath it. She cut down another leg, a bit higher, but almost got clipped by its forelegs when that slowed her down a little. She also had to dodge more ichor from the wounds in its belly. And the stench…

Gagging, she rolled out from underneath the bug right when it tried to lean on one side and then squash her flat using its whole body. It couldn't stop itself in time, and the earth shook a little when its belly hit it.

Catra was already moving, dashing around the monster, avoiding the flailing limbs as it tried to stand up again. She dodged left, then right, as the barbed tips slashed down, impaling themselves in the ground near her, then jumped and sailed over the monster’s mandibles when it tried to bite her and landed on its head.

“Game over!” she hissed and raked her claws over its eyes, then through the base of its antennas.

The monster’s scream almost deafened her, and she was flung off its head when the bug started convulsing, but the bush behind her cushioned her fall. “No more tracking me!” she spat as she got up.

The bug tore up the earth around it, then crashed into a tree - and started to batter it with its remaining limbs, sending chunks of bark and wood flying through the air.

Catra was tempted to put the thing out of its misery, but she had spent too long already - and their fight might have already drawn the attention of anyone hunting her.

So she booked it on all fours, dashing through the underbrush to gain some distance. She jumped on low-hanging branches to change direction and throw off any pursuit, taking random turns until she was so far away that she didn't hear the monster's cries any more.

And had gotten thoroughly lost in the process. Though that could be easily fixed by climbing a tall tree and looking for landmarks. Or just for the sun’s position. A rough idea of her location would be enough, anyway - it wasn't as if she was going to call in artillery barrages or air strikes.

But just as she was about to climb the tallest tree in her vicinity, she stopped and sniffed the air. What the…? She blinked. That smelt like… fresh pie? In the middle of the Whispering Wood.

Oh. That could only be one person. Madame Razz.

For a moment, she hesitated. Madame Razz was… ‘weird’ was the most polite way Catra would describe her. She had only met the woman a few times, with Adora, but that had been a little disturbing. Maybe a bit more than a little. Madame Razz lived in a different world - maybe literally, if what Entrapta had once speculated. Something about experiencing multiple times at once.

Of course, the old woman could simply be senile and mix up the past and the present. That would explain how she kept calling Adora ‘Mara’. But if Madame Razz had actually met Mara, Adora's predecessor as She-Ra, then that would mean that she was as old - maybe older - than Angella.

And a woman who had lived that long, in the middle of the monster-infested Whispering Woods, going senile was a scary thought. Hell, a woman who had lived that long was scary enough without mixing up people in her brain or living in multiple times.

So, it might be better for Catra to head in the other direction, away from the smell of fresh pie, and not risk even more trouble. On the other hand, maybe this Madame Razz could help her? Did she know that Angella wasn't the original Angella of this dimension?

And hiding from an old woman who spent her days baking pies and carrying a broom with her wasn't really Catra's style, no matter in which dimension she might be.

Scoffing, she started to follow the smell of pie.

It didn't take her long, of course, to find the small hut in which the woman lived - Catra's nose was good but not good enough to smell pie from a mile away. She just had to move through a number of denser bushes - picked clean of berries, she noticed - and travel along a small creek. No traces of animals, much less monster tracks, as far as she could tell. That was a good sign, right?

Whatever.

Stopping at the edge of the small clearing in which the hut stood, she cocked her head to the side and listened. She could hear a faint mumbling from the hut. So, Madame Razz was home.

Catra stepped into the clearing and approached the hut. “Hello? Anybody home?”

The mumbling stopped, and Madame Razz's head appeared in the small window to the side, above the cooling pie. “Oh, Mara, dearie! No, you're not Mara.”

“I am Catra,” Catra said, smiling without showing her fangs. “But I’m not the Catra from this dimension. I accidentally was transported here when I helped Adora fight evil aliens.”

The woman stared at her. “You're Horde.”

Catra clenched her teeth. “Not any more.” She wasn't in the Horde any more. She wasn't that Catra any more. She wasn't.

“Horde.” Razz was scowling at her. “In my forest!”

“I am not Horde any more!” Catra snapped. She blinked. Right, the clothes. “I'm wearing these like Adora does - because they are practical and comfortable. But I am not Horde. I am not from this dimension at all!” And because you're used to them, a small voice in the back of her head whispered.

“Horde!”

“NO! I am not Horde!” Catra took a deep breath. Calm. Keep calm, she told herself. Stay polite and friendly. Explain things. “I am from another dimension - another world. Like… You know Mara took Etheria into another dimension?”

“Mara dearie! My Mara was so brave!”

“Yes, she was.” Catra pressed her lips together. “And I am from another dimension where we saved Etheria from the Heart of Etheria. And from the Horde.”

“Horde!” Another scowl and broom-waving followed.

Catra raised her arms. “No, I'm not Horde. I am not from here.” How often did she have to repeat that? “The Horde here was defeated anyway!” With extreme prejudice - Angella had said so.

“Horde!”

This was… Catra narrowed her eyes. “Mara came from the First Ones.”

“Mara, dearie! My Mara was so brave!” Razz was smiling.

“And she fought Horde Prime.”

“Horde!” And Razz was scowling.

This was… This Razz was not acting like the Madame Razz Catra knew. Not at all. Madame Razz was weird, yes. Maybe senile. But she did listen to people. She answered questions or ignored them; she didn't just spit out words like this.

Catra frowned. Something was wrong. Very wrong. And… “Where's Loo-Kee?” She hadn't seen the little cat pixie at all so far, she realised. And back home, he had been fascinated by her - apparently, Catra had been the biggest cat he had ever seen, so he had come out of hiding. He hadn't done that for Adora, Catra knew.

Razz didn't answer.

“Loo-Kee. Your friend,” Catra prompted her.

Razz still didn't answer. She didn't react at all.

“Did the Horde capture him?” Catra asked.

“Horde!” And there was the scowl and the broom-shaking. Like before. *Exactly* like before. If Loo-Kee had been captured or killed by the Horde, wouldn't she have reacted more strongly? Differently? “Mara was brave, wasn't she?”

“Oh, Mara, Dearie!”

Catra felt her stomach drop. Something was very, very wrong here. Sure, it was possible that this dimension's Loo-Kee simply

had never met Madame Razz. And that this Madame Razz was different from the one she knew. Different dimension, different people.

But somehow, Catra suspected this wasn't the case. Madame Razz felt just too… wrong. Off.

Flat.

Like a bot of sorts.

Catra clenched her teeth and moved away from the hut. She had to think about this. But not here. Not when she had no idea how this Razz would act. Or what she could do.

*****

Alliance Base 'Gateway', PU-9623, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

"I should have gotten veto powers for naming bases," Jack muttered as he skimmed over a report and saw the official name of the newly-christened base they had overtaken.

"Hm?" Daniel asked, looking up from his own work.

"Nothing." They had already discussed the name. Daniel saw nothing wrong with it.

"Ah." And Jack's friend went back to reading whatever files his tablet had received with the latest update, leaving Jack to return to his paperwork.

Which mostly consisted of reports and notices. Lots of long, detailed reports and notices. "I can't believe Hammond complained about me not writing lengthy reports," Jack said. "I was saving him so much time."

Daniel didn't react.

Jack sighed - loudly - and skimmed the next report. Oh. He groaned. Space Systems Command - Jack liked to call them Spazzies - wanted a detailed report of the current operation in PU-9623 in order to reevaluate troop transport capacities for the Constitution II-class of frigates. Carter wouldn't like that. Not at all.

"What's wrong?" Daniel asked.

"The Navy pukes want to know if their boondoggle of a frigate design can be turned into a landing ship," Jack explained. "Without sacrificing any other capabilities it's supposed to have."

Daniel blinked. "I thought they were already building the ships? Sam mentioned that a while ago."

"They are." Jack bared his teeth in a twisted smile.

"Oh."

"Yeah. They probably plan to adjust the next batch." At least, Jack hoped the Navy pukes weren't as crazy as to redesign the ships already close to launch.

"Ah. That sounds… sensible?" Daniel smiled a bit weakly when Jack frowned at him. "I mean, incorporating battle experience is supposed to be a good thing, right?"

"If done right," Jack said. "After what Carter told me about the design process so far, I doubt they are doing it right." he shook his head. "We are getting dedicated troop transports - we don't need our frigates to be able to double as landing ships. In a pinch, Horde frigates can use their shuttles to land troops."

Daniel nodded. "So, tell them that?"

"I will." Not that it would help. Jack expected them to ignore his opinion just as they ignored Carter's opinion. Worst case, they'd try to enlarge the next batch of ships and end up with even worse designs. He checked the names of the admirals involved. Just in

case they might end up involved with a combat mission of his command. "Some officers are only fit to command museum ships," he muttered.

"The Navy actually doesn't run museum ships," Daniel told him.

"What?" Jack stared at him.

His friend blushed. "Ah, I once asked when my class visited one."

Ah. Jack nodded. "Good. Some people - like Kearsy - would probably manage to sink a museum ship."

Daniel snorted.

And Jack adjusted the report's priority. Carter was already busy with the portal projectors; she didn't need any distractions, especially not something as dumb as this request.

No, he could take care of that. It might even be fun to find the best ways to call everyone behind this an idiot without violating the Alliance regulations…

*****

Outside Alliance Base 'Gateway', PU-9623, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Adora crouched down at the base of the wall and checked the material. It was solid. And the former creek facing it was dry. As it should be - there was no need to run a stream through the base in the first place. It only made the base more vulnerable. And it wasn't hygienic at all. She had to suppress a shudder when she remembered how they had infiltrated the base through that creek.

But they had fixed that - the creek was rerouted around the base, and the base itself had a decent sewage system now - one that wasn't a security weakness waiting to happen. Tok'ra technology was very good for that stuff; their allies knew all about building secure bases.

“There you are!”

Adora turned and stood, facing her friend. “You told me to go outside.” And to stop bothering Entrapta, Sam, Bow and Hordak while they worked.

Glimmer nodded with a wide grin. “I wasn’t sure, though. That you’d actually do it, I mean. So, I first checked if you were not trying to hide in the lab.”

Adora glared at her. “I’m not that bad!”

“You’re worse!” Glimmer snorted, then grew serious. “We’ll find her,” she said.

“I know,” Adora lied. Her friends were geniuses. They had a lot of experience with this kind of project. And they had made a lot of progress. Adora knew all that, had seen them at work, and yet couldn’t help worrying.

Glimmer twitched for a moment - probably unconsciously tried to teleport - and then walked up to her and put her hand on Adora’s shoulder. “Hey, you know Catra. She’s tough. And smart. You know how much trouble she gave us.” With a laugh that sounded a little forced - Adora could tell - she added: “If whoever is living in the other dimension tries anything, she probably will conquer half of the world there before we arrive.”

Adora chuckled weakly. “Yeah. Like in the Crimson Waste.” Scorpia had told her about that trip.

“Well, let’s hope she doesn’t take over bandits this time,” Glimmer said. “Or starts a war.”

“Catra wouldn’t do that!” Adora protested. “Not without a good reason, at least,” she added.

Glimmer giggled. It sounded more honest this time.

And Adora felt a bit better.

But she still worried. Catra was alone in an unknown dimension where people disappeared - a dimension that reacted to your thoughts, according to Beta. Catra had changed, but… Some of her thoughts could be pretty dark.

*****

Refugee Camp, PU-9623, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Goddess!”

“Goddess!”

“She-Ra!”

“Your Divine Highness!”

Adora couldn't help grimacing as the slaves they had saved and freed from Taweret surrounded her. She wasn't a goddess. She was just doing what she could to save and protect people in need - as everyone should.

Still, she smiled. “Hello, everyone.” At least they had stopped kneeling. But Adora was pretty sure that had only happened because the clones had told them that she didn't like it, not because they had stopped worshipping her. But she'd take what she could get. And the slaves had been abused so much, literally left for dead and used in experiments by someone they worshipped as a god - even the workers had, apparently, been amongst the most loyal of Apophis - Adora couldn't bring herself to rebuke them again. It would be like breaking their trust as Taweret had done. Once they had recovered a bit more, she'd address the worshipping problem.

“Did you find our missing people, Goddess?” Kuta called out.

Adora smiled at him. Kuta was always respectful and he called her Goddess, but that was it - he didn't bow and scrape as much as many of the others or prayed to her. “We are working on it,” she

told him. “We'll soon launch the first attempt to save them from where Taweret sent them.”

Kuat scowled at hearing Taweret's name but nodded. Adora couldn't tell if he believed her, but that was kind of reassuring as well.

She didn't want blind obedience, much less blind faith.

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter frowned as she adjusted the Portal Projector’s power controls again. They had managed to change the settings to narrow down the projector's area of effect to what was effectively a micro-portal - so small, apart from air molecules, not much else would be transported, but it would be usable for communication, at least for electronic bursts as long as they were perfectly synchronised. Two-way communication would need not only a longer duration but an actual portal, not just a transport effect, though, and the power requirements for that were off the scale, even with a reduced area of effect. But maybe, if she managed to raise the efficiency a bit more…

“Check out the new readings!”

Sam looked up at Bow's exclamation. He sounded concerned - and he didn't get excited easily, unlike, say, Entrapta.

Sam’s friend was already moving over, carried by her hair, to look at Bow’s console. “Yes? Oh! That's unexpected!”

Sam joined them and took a look at the latest sensor readings from the target dimension. A moment later, she pressed her lips together so she wouldn't curse.

Usually, they detected foreign sapients in the target dimension by the small changes caused by the other dimension adapting to

them as their minds affected it. Effects akin to small ripples that quickly vanished the further they went.

Now, it was different. If the changes had been ripples before, then they were waves now. And they were spreading without vanishing - and amplifying each other, it seemed. “Bring up the earlier data!” she snapped.

“Already on it,” Bow replied, and the data on the screen expanded. “Putting it on the main screen.”

Sam turned as the holographic display in the centre of the room changed, the depiction of the local system vanishing and being replaced by sensor data. “Cascading changes…” she muttered.

“What is going on?” Entrapta asked. “It's like… like an entire area of the dimension is changing drastically!”

Sam didn't know what was happening, but she doubted it was a good thing. “Let's call the others!” she said. “They need to know this!”

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Unknown Location, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

What was wrong with this Razz? Even after a few hours pondering the question, Catra hadn't found an answer. She took a bite out of the fish she had caught and grilled and sighed.

Was the old woman actually a bot? Some sort of decoy? But if she had been a bot, who would have created her and why? Or was she just going senile? Was that going to happen to Madame Razz back home as well? But if that were the case, wouldn't this dimension's Adora have done something? You couldn't leave a senile old woman in a monster-infested forest by herself, no matter how much some of the creatures there might like her.

And what about Loo-Kee? The Razz back home considered him a friend, but this Razz didn't seem to know him at all. Was that just

a difference between their dimensions? And what effects would that have had? It wasn't as if the little pixie had been crucial for the Horde war, so things would have still worked out the same. Probably. On the other hand, Loo-Kee had been important for Razz. And Catra had kind of liked the little tyke herself - she still needed to introduce Luna to him. If he were here…

She blinked as she heard a familiar noise. Think of the devil? Turning, she spotted a small face staring at her from the underbrush. ”Loo-Kee?”

He smiled and jumped out of the bush, approaching her. “Hello!”

He sounded like Catra's Loo-Kee. And he was as friendly as she remembered him - once he had overcome his shyness. And she was meeting this dimension's Loo-Kee for the first time… This was too much of a coincidence. Something was very wrong here.

She narrowed her eyes when whatever this creature was eyed her fish like Loo-Kee would have. “I caught it,” she hissed before she could control herself.

In return, the pixie made the most pitiful expression at her, sniffling as his big eyes started to grow wet.

“Oh, for…” Catra rolled her eyes and ripped off a piece of her meal. “That's all you're gonna get, though, you hear?”

“Thanks!” Loo-Kee started munching on it, and Catra studied him some more. He looked like she remembered him. *Exactly* like she remembered him, down to small details.

And only those, she realised. She didn't spot anything she might have forgotten. Oh. Was that…?

The sound of an explosion interrupted her thoughts. That had been… either too close or too powerful. Either way, it sounded like bad news. Catra stuck the rest of the fish in her mouth and jumped up the closest tree trunk, quickly climbing up.

She had to jump to another, taller tree but quickly found herself above the canopy, overlooking the forest. A huge cloud of smoke was rising from the edge of the forest, where Plumeria was located. And floating in the smoke, slowly emerging…

Catra hissed. That was a Ha'tak! In this dimension?

Her ears twitched as she heard a voice from the ship. A familiar voice - a Goa'uld. Amplified enough so her ears could pick it up even at this distance.

“I AM YOUR GOD! BOW TO ME!”

Apophis.

*****

The Lost Dimension Part 2

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...and that's the situation."

Jack O'Neill nodded when Carter finished. "So… the dimension we're trying to reach is changing massively, and we don't know why."

"We have several theories, sir," Carter replied. She sounded a little annoyed. Probably both at his flippant summary and the fact that she didn't have an answer.

"And the changes have actually stopped - kinda," Entrapta added. "Well, they aren't accelerating any more. And it seems as if they are kinda fading again."

"Ah." Adora nodded. "So, things are going back to normal?" She looked relieved.

Jack could understand that. He felt better at hearing that as well.

"That depends on how you define normal," Entrapta said.

And Jack was back to worrying.

"It could be that the changes recede," Bow said, pointing at a wall of numbers and tables that Jack didn't bother studying. "But it could also be that the changes are settling in, sort of."

"One possible explanation for the fact that we cannot detect any more changes after a while is that the changes caused by sapient visitors become the norm in the target dimension after a while," Carter said.

"So… a huge part of the dimension just changed completely, and that's now normal for the dimension?" Adora asked.

Glimmer shook her head. “How can anyone live there?”

“The target dimension is greatly and easily affected by sapient minds. We already knew that,” Hordak cut in. “That malleable reality is the norm for the dimension. As far as native life is concerned, sapients would likely be able to form their own area of control and create a stable zone to inhabitate.” He paused for a moment and cocked his head. “That is if there are actually native sapient life forms. Given what we know about this dimension, we should have detected constant changes on a much larger scale. Although if all sapients of the dimension are brought in line with each other, so consensus about their reality is achieved, the dimension itself would be quite stable, I assume.”

That was… A world where reality only remained real while everyone agreed that this was the way it should be? Jack grimaced. “I don’t think that would work. There’s always someone who disagrees with how things should be.”

“Perhaps amongst humans. But not every civilisation follows your example,” Hordak retorted. “When Horde Prime ruled us, none of us would deviate from his wishes. Not for long, in any case.”

“Only until you got mindwiped or chipped,” Jack commented. He ignored the frown on Hordak’s face. The former warlord had spent decades trying to conquer Etheria for Horde Prime; he could take a reminder about how wrong that had been.

“In theory, such a society could be formed without mind control,” Carter said. “For example, a hive mind species would naturally form a consensus. And such a species would be adapted well to a dimension where reality itself can be changed by your mind.”

That sounded logical - as expected from Carter. Daniel nodded as well, in obvious agreement. And yet… Jack frowned. “And how would such a species deal with, ah, visitors from afar who aren’t connected to their hive mind?”

Judging by the grimaces on everyone's faces, the answer wasn't going to be 'nicely'.

*****

"They're going to mind control Catra?" Adora gasped. She wouldn't let that happen again! The first time had almost destroyed Catra - would have actually killed her, if not for She-Ra's power!

"It's a theory," Sam said. "We don't know if the dimension has native sapient life."

"But since it has, you know, kinda fixed structures as our sensors tell us, and is not constantly changing randomly, I think there are sapients there," Entrapta pointed out. "Someone has shaped the dimension so we can track changes to it. And someone clearly was fetching everyone who arrived away - at least, that's the most likely explanation for their rapid change of position after arrival."

Adora clenched her teeth. Someone was rounding up the people who entered the dimension. And for what? To control them? To keep them from changing the dimension? If they did anything to Catra, she would… Adora drew a deep breath. She had to control herself. Catra was tough and smart. She wouldn't let herself get caught easily. Adora had to trust her lover. Even if it was hard. "So, when we enter the dimension, we'll meet whoever is collecting visitors."

"That's what we think, yes," Bow said. "All the data points to that."

"Good. Then we can talk to them right away and get Catra and the others back." Adora nodded. And if they didn't want to listen, then she would *make* them give everyone back. Even if there was no magic in the dimension - they hadn't checked for that yet - she would still have She-Ra's power.

Nothing and no one would stand in her way. She'd save Catra. And the others.

“Ah.” Daniel cleared his throat. “I have a question.”

“Yes?” Entrapta turned to smile at him.

He nodded. “If we arrive there as a group, how will that affect the target dimension?” He smiled a little sheepishly. “I know we are on the same wavelength, so to speak, so would we affect the dimension more strongly than a single visitor?”

“Probably yes,” Sam said. She frowned. “We haven’t tested that for obvious reasons. But we would likely have a bigger impact on the dimension than if we arrived spread out. In fact…” She trailed off.

“Oh! If we create an amplifying effect, we could probably start a huge change as well!” Entrapta beamed.

“Or we should take precautions so we don’t start changing someone else’s dimension,” Bow said. “They might see that as an attempt to attack them.”

He was right. But should they split up?

“Never split the party,” Jack said as if he had read Adora’s mind. “We can’t let them pick us up one by one.”

Adora nodded. They could always apologise to whoever was concerned. And, she thought, feeling a bit guilty, it might help them get their people back.

*****

Samantha Carter took a short breath. “We don’t have a way to mitigate our impact on the target dimension yet, sir. We don’t know enough about the mechanics of the entire process.” Nothing beyond the fact that sapient minds affected the dimension, but she didn’t say that. “We don’t know what triggered this massive change. Was it a critical mass of aligned minds? Or is there a build-up that reaches a trigger step over time?” In which case

they might be able to enter the dimension and stay for some time before affecting it on such a scale.

"Although we're pretty sure that the changes originated from the people who were sent there from Beta," Entrapta added. "The changes grew from previous, weaker effects that we picked up on our sensors. Probably - we still need to confirm that with another test. It could also just be a correlation."

"And correlation does not imply causation," Daniel said, nodding. "Ah… it could just be a coincidence that the effect started where previous, ah, travellers were."

"Ah."

"In theory," Entrapta said. "Our sensors weren't calibrated precisely enough to discern that when it happened. But they will be next time!"

"We're not going to wait for a next time," Adora said. "We can't."

Sam knew that. But she also knew that they shouldn't be blindly charging in either. But it was obvious that Adora's patience was running out. And neither the General nor Glimmer was trying to step in.

They needed more data and more time to analyse this new development. But Sam didn't think they would get it. The best she could probably do was to ensure they were not rushing things too much - she could at least make the actual translocation as safe as possible. "We'll need to run a few tests so we can confirm that we'll be able to retrieve the rescue party," she said.

"Do it," Adora said.

*****

Unknown Location, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Plumeria was burning. Even from this far away, it looked worse than when the Horde under Catra had taken it. Of course, Catra had been limited to Horde ground forces and air support, not a Ha'tak floating above the kingdom while Death Gliders and Al'keshs strafed and bombed what the ship's cannons had missed.

She shook her head, clenching her teeth when another pillar of smoke rose on the horizon. It didn't look as if Apophis was planning to conquer the kingdom - it looked as if he wanted to wipe it out. And was doing a good job of it. Probably trying to make an example out of it to impress the rest of this Etheria.

But Plumeria wasn't a good choice for that. From a military point of view, it was the weakest kingdom of the Princess Alliance. Not the least important - Perfuma alone was crucial for the logistics of the Alliance - but as far as defences and combat capability were concerned, it was a pushover, at least if you had operational surprise and the means to move enough forces in before the rest of the Alliance could react. Catra had proven this.

So, this wouldn't scare the princesses into surrender. Not that anything would - they had not surrendered to Horde Prime either. But it would enrage the princesses. Maybe even this dimension's Perfuma and Entrapta. But Glimmer, Frosta and Mermista would be furious and mobilising their forces.

At least Angella would prevent reckless attacks that would only play right into Apophis's hand. But even so… Catra looked at the floating spaceship again. The princesses here had no idea what they were facing. If they treated this like another Horde invasion, not knowing what the Goa'uld could do, things could end in a catastrophe. And if Apophis or one of his underlings managed to possess a princess…

Damn! She hissed. She knew better than anyone else here what the Goa'uld were like. She had to warn the Alliance here.

Turning, she took a look at Bright Moon, visible in the distance. That was too far to reach on foot in time. But Alliance soldiers

must have been sent to look for her. And they would be in contact with Adora and Angella.

She snorted as she jumped from branch to branch towards the ground. All that effort to get away, and now she had to double back and hope that her pursuers were close.

And that they didn't try to shoot her on sight. Not that they would succeed, but if she had to take their communicator by force, it would complicate things with the Alliance even further.

She reached the ground and looked around. "Loo-Kee?"

No answer. The little pixie was gone. Probably scared into hiding. And Catra had no time to waste on looking for him. He should be safe enough in the woods here, anyway.

*****

The explosions had stopped about fifteen minutes after Catra had started running and hadn't picked up for the next hour. So, Apophis was done with Plumeria. But the Death Gliders and Al'keshs would be spreading out already, doing recon if he was cautious. Or attacking targets of opportunity if he was reckless and thought all the kingdoms on Etheria were as easy to destroy as Plumeria.

She almost hoped it would be the latter. It wasn't a nice thought, but a few bombing runs on other kingdoms would make the Alliance focus on defence instead of launching an attack on the Ha'tak. And while they were protecting their people, they were not trying to charge an enemy they knew nothing about.

Which should make it easier for Catra to help them with defeating Apophis. And to stay out of Angella's dungeons. Or so she hoped. Angella might think that this was all a ploy of Catra - probably cite the timing of Catra's escape as suspicious or something.

Maybe Catra would have to shoot down a Death Glider or board an Al'kesh to prove her goodwill. Though either would be hard

without a plane of her own. Or at least a heavy weapon.

Her ears twitched. That sounded like a pair of Death Gliders passing overhead! Headed in the direction of Bright Moon! She didn't hear more craft, though. Recon then - even Apophis wouldn't expect two Death Gliders to defeat Bright Moon.

But after this, attack runs would follow. To probe Bright Moon's defences, possibly to degrade them before the main attack was launched.

She hissed under her breath as she jumped over a fallen tree that looked vaguely familiar. She had to reach Bright Moon before Apophis launched a full attack. Trying to talk to the princesses would be impossible in the middle of a siege - especially if she couldn't get through the shield.

So, where were the Bright Moon soldiers hunting her? It would be ironic if she had managed to lose her pursuers when she needed them to find her.

She kept running, though not all-out. She had to pace herself. Worst case, she had to run all the way to Bright Moon. And she'd probably arrive just in time to see the Ha'tak start bombarding the palace…

Another explosion interrupted her thoughts. Close or just massive? It had sounded close, but… She looked up but could only see the dense foliage above.

Wait! She blinked - that was the sound of a Death Glider pulling high-g turns! Over the Whispering Woods? She had to check what was happening!

Snarling, she changed course towards the thickest tree trunk she could see nearby. Bark flew as she scaled it as quickly as possible, her claws ripping into the wood and through foliage and branches.

As she raced upwards, she heard more explosions - and staff weapons firing. No doubt, someone was fighting the Jaffa!

She reached the top of the tree and peered up. Where…? There! A Death Glider was turning, trying to shoot… Swift Wind?

Catra stared. The flying horse was dogfighting the Death Glider? "If my Swift Wind ever tries that with Adora in the saddle, I'll kill him myself!" she spat as the Death Glider pilot overshot Swift Wind again. And what was Adora doing? Trying to hit the thing with her sword?

Catra blinked as Adora tried to do exactly that. "Oh, for…!" she exclaimed. "Why don't you shoot some magic beam at it?"

Adora didn't reply - hadn't heard her. But the Death Glider decided to stop trying to dogfight and broke off, easily leaving Swift Wind behind. Fleeing? A Jaffa?

No, not fleeing. The Death Glider turned and started an attack run. So, the pilot knew how to zoom and boom, as Jack called it.

And Adora met him head-on, sword flashing as she deflected the blasts aimed at her! Catra held her breath. It wasn't her Adora, the outfit was wrong, but… She couldn't help smiling at the sight. Still, deflecting staff weapon fire, while impressive, wouldn't defeat the Death Glider, so…

She gasped. Adora jumped off Swift Wind, directly into the path of the passing Death Glider, blade held in both hands. The Jaffa pilot tried to dodge but was too slow - and Adora's sword tore off its wing, sending the craft tumbling into the forest below.

Catra barely registered the explosion that followed - she was watching Adora fall. Of course, She-Ra was tough, but from that height, even her Adora would feel it. Although if the trees broke her fall…

But before Adora could hit the canopy, Swift Wind swept in, catching her on his back as he pulled up from a dive that should have carried him straight into the woods.

Catra took a deep breath. They had done it. But if the Jaffa pilot had been a bit better, or kept his distance more, if he had caught Swift Wind catching Adora… She clenched her teeth and yelled: “You idiot! What were you thinking?”

Swift Wind jerked to the side, then turned around.

Apparently, they had heard Catra.

Well, she had wanted to make contact with the Alliance anyway, hadn't she?

So she stayed and put on the best, most confident smile that she could as Adora approached on Swift Wind.

“Catra!” The scowl on Adora's face made Catra reconsider her decision, but the die was cast or whatever the saying was.

“Adora.” She nodded, shifting her weight slightly so she could jump off the branch if she needed to. “What were you thinking, trying to dogfight a Death Glider? If the pilot had been halfway competent, Swift Wind would have been dead.”

“I am She-Ra's loyal steed! We are bound together!” Swift Wind protested. “No enemy can match us when we are fighting together!”

“Someone needs to tell that to Apophis over there in his Ha'tak,” Catra commented with a snort.

“So, you're behind this!” Adora spat, pointing her sword at her.

Catra tried to ignore the blade, which was a bit too close to her - especially since it bopped up and down; Swift Wind's hovering was not exactly that stable. “You idiot! I've told you before, I'm not your Catra. I'm from a different dimension, where we - the Princess Alliance and others - are fighting the Goa'uld.” She pointed at the Ha'tak, which was still hovering over what remained of Plumeria. “That's Apophis, one of the Goa'uld System

Lords. He is an alien snake that burrows into you and takes over your body."

"I'm not falling for your tricks again!"

Oh, for…! "It's not a trick." Catra cocked her head. Time for a little gamble. "Didn't a bunch of people arrive like I did, sent here by Taweret? Apophis's Queen?"

Adora blinked. "They mentioned Apophis… But they said he was their god. They didn't say he'd attack us!"

OK, this Adora really was an idiot! "The Goa'uld pose as gods and use technology to fool their slaves and followers." Which were slaves in all but names, but best not to confuse this Adora further. "We've been fighting them to free their slaves. We've already defeated many such ships."

Adora narrowed her eyes at her. "I don't believe you! You're a liar! Always were!"

"You don't know me!" Catra spat. "I'm not your Catra, and you're not my Adora!" She glared at Swift Wind for good measure. "And you're not my dimension's Swift Wind. He's busy freeing horses."

"She-Ra and I share a sacred bond!"

That was… stupid even for Swift Wind. Like… She closed her eyes. Not again! "Whatever!" She turned back to Adora. "Take me to Angella so I can tell her about Apophis before he starts destroying the next kingdom." The Queen at least knew that Catra was from another dimension. Catra hoped that Angella was smart enough to realise that she needed Catra's help more than she needed to keep her quiet about Angella's own extradimensional origin.

"Are you surrendering?" Adora was still frowning, with that mulish expression she sometimes had when things were not going her way.

“I am telling you to take me to Angella so I can give her crucial information about this new enemy,” Catra retorted. “If you want to call that surrendering, be my guest.”

Adora scoffed. “Don't try anything!” Then she reached over - faster than Catra expected, but not fast enough that Catra wouldn't have been able to dodge if she had wanted to - grabbed her by the scruff of her neck and pulled her up. “I'm watching you!”

Catra froze for a moment. This was… not her Adora, she reminded herself as she was sat down in front of Adora on Swift Wind's back. Not my Adora, she silently repeated herself when she felt a muscular arm wrap around her stomach and hold her in place - with a familiar body pressing into her back.

“Let's fly back to Bright Moon!”

“Away we go!”

Not my Adora, Catra told herself once again as they flew off. Even if she feels and smells like her.

She couldn't let herself relax and enjoy this.

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Technically, this wasn't Jack O'Neill's decision. He might be a general now, in charge of Alliance Special Forces Command, but Adora was the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, and she had decided that they would enter the ‘target dimension’. They really needed a better name for it, actually. He couldn't just keep calling it that. Daniel said to wait until they knew what the natives of the dimension called it, something about not presuming to name another dimension, but even a string of letters and numbers would be OK as a temporary measure.

Anyway, this wasn't Jack's decision, but if it were up to him, he'd make the same decision. You didn't leave your people behind or give them up - you got them back. And that was what they would be doing. No matter the cost.

Though the cost might be high in this case. If their arrival caused one of those cascading change thingies, and the natives thought this was an attack, then this could mean war. War with an entire other dimension, even if it wasn't particularly large. And a dimension where your thoughts could shape reality. Whether you wanted it or not.

Heh, if it came to war, could they imagine a big honking spaceship to appear on their side? That would be a novel way to fight a war. People were always trying to outthink the enemy in war, but to out-imagine the enemy was new.

Unless you counted some of the research proposals he had seen submitted to the Alliance. Those were so outrageous, they were clearly the result of an overly active imagination. Or greed.

Whatever. Jack checked his gear again, then checked his tab for urgent reports. Nothing.

He had nothing to do but wait for Carter and the others to finish their setup.

Well, he could check up on the others to keep busy, at least.

*****

Adora knew she should be doing something helpful. Maybe talk to the freed slaves again, help them get adjusted. Inspect the base above. Make sure that everything was going well. Check the reports and files sent from Alliance HQ.

But she had already done most of the paperwork - well, the important parts. OK, the really important, urgent parts. And Glimmer had told her that she was just stressing the Alliance soldiers if she kept checking things. And heading to the freed

slaves again… Being worshipped and thanked was embarrassing on a good day, but being fawned over while she couldn't save her lover? No, thanks. She didn't need that.

“Here you are!”

She looked up from her tablet - not that she had actually been reading whatever file was on the screen - and frowned at Jack. “You know that this is serving as my office.” He also had an office in the research station, even if he spent more time in the break room.

“Yep. But I figured you were in the labs, ready to jump into another dimension as soon as Carter and the others finish the thingie.” He grinned.

She frowned some more. “I would just distract them.” Bow had told her so discreetly. Hordak had done so not so discreetly.

He shrugged and sat down on the chair in the corner of her office. “Someone has to keep an eye on them to make sure they don't push themselves too hard.”

But Catra was in danger! Adora pressed her lips together and swallowed her words. It wouldn't do anyone any good if her friends hurt themselves by working too hard. Or too much. “Glimmer's with them.” And she wouldn't let them do anything stupid.

“Yeah. She shooed me out.” He rubbed his neck as he moved his head. “They're doing what they can,” he added in a quieter, more serious tone.

“I know.” She narrowed her eyes. “You don't need to keep an eye on me.”

He smiled, not showing any embarrassment at being caught. “Doesn't hurt, though, does it?”

Of course, it didn't.

He leaned forward, hands on his thighs. “Want to talk about it?”

No need to mention what he meant. Or whom. “No.” She didn’t want to talk about it. She just wanted to go and save Catra. As soon as possible.

“OK.” He nodded and leaned back, pulling his own tablet out of his pocket. And ignored the frown she aimed at him.

She didn't need a watcher. But if she said so, she would sound childish. And having someone else here was… well, not bad. Kind of nice.

She went back to staring at the file before blinking and looking at Jack again. The way his hands were moving… “Are you playing a game?”

“Yep.”

“On your tablet?”

“Yep.”

Oh. She hadn't known they had games for their tablets - they were compatible with Earth computer files, but that shouldn’t include games. As Entrapta had explained once, adapting text files and other data was easy, but they had to basically copy the word processors and other programs Earth used to run on Etherian systems. So… She groaned. “That's what they call piracy on Earth.” Glimmer had complained about that. As had Sea Hawk, though he had been offended for the sake of ‘real pirates’.

“We aren't on Earth, are we?” His grin widened. “And rules are always less strict in the field.”

She snorted and shook her head, then went back to her paperwork.

“We'll get her back. Safe and sound.”

She smiled without looking up again.

*****

“Alright. The latest batch of tests looks good!” Entrapta announced. “We did manage to confirm that communication is possible through micro-portals as long as we rig the communicators to broadcast before the portal opens.” She beamed.

Samantha Carter nodded. “We’ll need to calibrate the systems to start broadcasting a bit before the set times, to compensate for any delays.”

“And if we improve the compression algorithms, we could have two-way verbal communication!” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically. “It'll be lagged, worse than talking over the spy bot network, but it would be possible. With enough power, we could project a microportal every ten seconds.”

“That would require more power than we currently have available here,” Sam pointed out. And the side effects from working the projector constantly would be nasty. Probably not strong enough to affect the seismic stability of the region - they were microportals, after all - but she would have to study the exact effects of the vibrations caused by the projector in more detail to exclude that danger.

“The strain on the systems operating them continuously during the mission would generate are unlikely to be worth it,” Hordak commented. “We might have equipment failures at the worst possible moment.”

Entrapta pouted. “And I guess we don't have the time to construct a secondary projector for communication.”

“I don’t think so,” Bow said. “But this is good enough. With the text-to-speech and speech-to-text routines, we can use verbal communication anyway.”

“It’s still going to suffer from a lot of lag,” Entrapta complained.

That couldn't be helped, in Sam's opinion. “We have a working system. That's good enough.”

“Does that mean we're ready to go?” Glimmer asked.

Sam drew a short breath. She would prefer to run a test with several travellers, sent to a remote location, to check the system before starting the mission. But Adora had made it clear that she wouldn't let anyone else take that risk, so they might as well not bother.

“The projector needs some maintenance,” Beta replied. “To ensure it will run perfectly after the latest tests. Then the mission can start.” Sam wondered if the bot would insist on such checks if it weren’t Adora going through.

“How long will that take?” Glimmer asked.

“About one and a half hours,” Sam told her. She had done that maintenance a lot over the last few days.

Glimmer nodded. “Alright. I'll tell the others.”

And they were committed.

*****

Unknown Location, February 3rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra was glad that they didn’t have to tangle with another Death Glider on the way to Bright Moon. This Adora might try to dogfight it again, and unlike her, Catra was not staff weapon-proof. At least, she didn’t think Adora would drop her off without landing if they were attacked. Though she couldn’t help wondering about that until they reached Bright Moon.

The shield was up - Catra saw it catch the light of the Third Moon of Enchantment - but as Adora approached, an opening appeared,

and they could pass through. As they circled above the central yard before landing, she looked up at the moon. “I wonder if Alpha’s on that moon as well.”

“What?” Adora spat.

“First Ones research station in my world,” Catra explained. “Alpha’s the bot running it. Like Light Hope, but more Entrapta.”

“What?” Adora repeated herself.

Swift Wind touched down amongst the guards who had gathered, and Catra snorted. “If Entrapta and Bow can repair Darla, we might visit.” She blinked and turned her head to look at Adora. “Wait! You got her back before you destroyed the Horde, right?”

But Adora scowled and grabbed her arms. “I don’t even know who Darla is!” she spat, then lifted Catra up and slid off Swift Wind’s back.

“Mara’s ship,” Catra replied, staggering as she was pushed towards the waiting guards. She saw Adora freezing for a moment, mouth half-open. That wasn’t a good sign. “The Horde recovered it in my world. Did you check if it’s still in the Crimson Waste?”

“Why should I bother?” Adora said, scowling even more.

“Because that’s our best chance to fight Apophis!” Catra blurted out. The guards grabbed her arms, and she squirmed for a moment, suppressing the urge to break their grip.

Adora scoffed. “Yeah, right.”

Catra clenched her teeth together. Why was this Adora such an idiot? “Do you have another spaceship on Etheria? Or are you trying to fight the Ha’tak with Swift Wind?”

“Our sacred bond allows us to defeat any foe!”

Catra ignored the fool and stared at Adora.

But the other woman scoffed. “We defeated the Horde. We will defeat those invaders as well!”

Catra groaned. “Let me talk to Angella.” Hopefully, the queen was not as stupid.

“She’s got other things to do than listen to you! Take her to the new cell!”

“Wait! I have critical intelligence about the enemy!” Catra dug her claws into the ground, making the guards trying to drag her away stumble for a second. “Have you forgotten your training? Intel is everything!” The Horde instructors had been quite clear about that.

Adora frowned again, looking confused for a moment.

Catra hissed under her breath. Adora couldn’t have forgotten her cadet training! “Just ask her if she needs intel!”

Adora narrowed her eyes but nodded. “I will.”

Catra started to relax - to think this idiot would have dropped her in a cell in the middle of a Goa’uld attack! - but was startled again when the two guards dragged her after Adora.

She considered scratching the floor inside the palace just to make a point - she was going along with this when she could have shredded those two - but decided not to push her luck. It was clear that her fate was hanging by a thread.

It didn’t take them long to reach the Alliance meeting room.

“I’ve taken down one enemy flyer and captured Catra!” Adora announced as she entered.

“I walked up to her and told her to take me here.” Catra stared at Angella. “I know this enemy. We’ve been fighting him in our

world.”

“Her world? What?” Glimmer blurted out.

“She’s with them!” Frosta jumped off her chair - still a bit too big for her - and started to walk towards Catra, ice appearing around her fist.

The other princesses whispered amongst each other.

Catra ignored them all and focused on Angella. She was the only one who mattered. Well, the Snow princess about to hit her with fists made of ice was a problem as well, but Catra knew she could take a punch from the shrimp, and Angella was calling the shots.

The queen glared at her for several seconds, then raised her hand. “Stop, Frosta!”

“But she admitted to working with the enemy!” Frosta whined. Hadn’t she grown up at all since the Princess Prom?

“Mom?” Glimmer looked confused. As did Adora, but that was nothing new.

Angella rose from her seat and walked toward Catra. “You know our enemy.”

“Apophis. We - the Princess Alliance and others - are fighting him and his fellow Goa’uld in our universe.” Catra grinned. “We’ve kicked his ass on his throne world and destroyed entire fleets of Ha’taks.”

“Oe of those razed Plumeria, and you claim to have destroyed fleets of those things?” Glimmer shook her head, then winced when Perfuma sniffled at hearing that.

Angella seemed to ignore both. “I find that hard to believe myself.”

“Well, we’ve got ships of our own.” Catra tried to straighten to face Angella on a more equal footing, but the two guards were still gripping her arms. “Better ships than Apophis has. Unfortunately, the only spaceship currently on Etheria is Mara’s old ship. In my universe, the Horde tried to recover it, but you got it back. But it seems that you forgot about it here.”

Angella drew a sharp breath - Catra caught her flinching for a moment - but when she spoke, she was all calm and collected. “The ship was not recovered here.”

“Then it’s still in the Crimson Waste,” Catra said. “You need to get it and repair it as soon as possible. Apophis won’t limit himself to destroying one kingdom. He’ll keep doing that until you surrender or are destroyed.”

Angella inclined her head a tiny bit. “He has sent us his demands.”

Catra wanted to shrug, but she was still held by the guards. “Well, play for time. It’ll take a lot of work to get Darla in the air again.”

“You don’t give us orders!” Glimmer spat.

Others agreed with her, but Catra glanced at Entrapta. The princess was rather quiet, which was a surprise. Ah, she was busy with her tool! Probably already planning the recovery operation.

Catra turned her head and met Angella’s eyes again.

The queen glared at her again, then turned to face the others. “She’s our enemy, but she’s correct: We will need a spaceship of our own to battle this new enemy. We’ll stall Apophis and recover She-Ra’s ship.”

“Yes!” Entrapta cheered. “More First Ones technology!”

Catra snorted. At least this Entrapta and her own were the same.

“And what will the spaceship do?” Glimmer asked, still frowning. “I remember it - it wasn't nearly as big as the one that… is attacking

us," she added with a glance at Perfuma.

"It might be enough to get a boarding team inside the Ha'tak," Catra replied. "It's First Ones technology, and even a thousand years ago, they were better than the Goa'uld. If it's not enough, you can use it to get to Alpha on the Third Moon of Enchantment. It's a First Ones research base, and there should be shuttles in the hangar there." This Entrapta might not be able to turn them into stealth shuttles, but they would be very useful in dealing with the Death Gliders and Al'keshs and offer quick transportation. "You could…" She trailed off as she realised that Angella had frozen up again.

"Alpha…" The queen shook her head, then stared at Catra with an unreadable expression. "You know about that?"

"Mom?" Glimmer sounded concerned.

"Angella?" Adora as well.

"A First Ones *research base* on a *moon*?" Entrapta sounded enthusiastic.

But Catra had, apparently, stumbled into another minefield. And it was all her fault - of course, Angella would be aware of Alpha! She had been created in the lab! "We found it in our world," she said.

"What is it? Mom?" Glimmer asked.

Catra clenched her teeth so she wouldn't blurt out the answer. Revealing the origin of the princesses in the middle of a Goa'uld invasion? As a suspected enemy? Yeah, right! They had to focus on the war at hand.

"It's where I was… born," Angella said.

Catra suppressed a groan as the room fell silent for a moment.

“You were born on the Third Moon of Enchantment?” Glimmer didn't quite screech, but it came close enough to hurt Catra's ears.

“You're a First One?” Adora blurted out.

“That's why Bright Moon lays claim to the moons!” Mermista apparently needed to work on her priorities as well.

Angella turned to look at Glimmer. “Yes. In the First Ones research station.” She turned to Adora. “No, I am not a First One.” She pressed her lips together. “Alpha made that very clear,” she added with a glance at Catra.

Catra winced. “Yeah, that figures.”

“What are you talking about?” Glimmer pouted at both of them. “I don't get it! Who is Alpha?”

Adora shook her head. “But… does that mean that Catra told the truth?”

“Don't act so shocked!” Catra hissed. Really, she wasn't *that* bad.

Angella straightened. “It's not important right now. We're in the middle of an invasion and must focus on that. We need to recover that spaceship and then board Apophis's ship. Before he destroys another kingdom.” She turned to Glimmer. “You will lead the recovery operation. Take Bow and Entrapta with you. And Adora,” she added.

“Alright, Mom.”

“The rest of us will do our best to stall the enemy,” Angella went on.

“Let's hope our best will be enough,” Mermista muttered. “We don't have flying ships.”

“Apophis will only reach Salineas over my dead body, my love!”

“That's what I'm afraid of.”

“Angella? Maybe I should stay as well. I can engage their flyers with Swift Wind,” Adroa suggested.

Oh, for…! Catra opened her mouth to tell the idiot off - she should know better! - but Angella shook her head.

“You need to go. It's She-Ra's ship,” she said. “And you're a First One. You will be needed to take control of it.”

Yeah, she definitely knew Alpha, Catra thought. Probably far too well.

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Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill suppressed a yawn as he approached the transport area. He should have slept a bit while waiting. Maybe if he hadn't raided Danel's coffee supply… But what was done was done.

Adora was, unsurprisingly, already standing there, in full She-Ra uniform, sword out. And she looked eager and ready, not tired at all despite the early hour. Of course, she was cheating with magic.

Glimmer yawned as she joined them, almost dragging her staff along the floor. But Teal'c looked alert as ever - of course, Jack's friend cheated with his Jaffa meditation thingie.

And Daniel was still hopped up on coffee, it seemed. Then again, he was always eager when it came to meeting new people. At least Sha're seemed to be sufficiently wary to keep him out of trouble if Jack was too busy.

“Alright!” Entrapta walked over, followed by Bow and Carter. “Hordak will be using the projector as soon as we're ready!”

Jack would have preferred someone else, but since Bow, Entrapta and Carter were coming with them, Hordak was the only choice left. Someone had to keep an eye on Beta as well, even though they had moved Taweret off-planet already. Just in case the bot got ideas about subverting authority again, what with both Jack and Adora going off-dimension.

He looked at the group. “Everyone ready?” They looked ready, at least. “Remember: No thinking of Marshmallow Men!” Daniel chuckled, and Carter rolled her eyes with a wry smile, which was about the best he could have hoped for, but the others looked lost. “We'll have to watch Ghostbusters together,” he said.

“But Jack is correct - we'll be shaping the dimension around us with our thoughts, so we should, ah, control ourselves,” Daniel said.

“The effects should be fairly limited according to our projections,” Carter said. “At least at the start.”

That was reassuring. “Then let's keep it that way,” Jack said. “Let's go.”

“Alright! Science Buddy, go!”

A moment later, Jack heard a humming noise, and then everything went white.

And then he was standing on grass. Tall grass. Vaguely familiar, he had seen… He trailed off and then cursed. They were on a hill, looking at a Ha'tak attacking Bright Moon, cannon fire splashing against a magic shield covering the entire town. Jack recognised the markings on the ship. “How the hell did Apophis arrive here before us?” he spat. “And why are we on Etheria?”

“Oh, no!” Daniel shook his head. “Uh. I don't think he arrived here before us, Jack. And this is probably not Etheria.”

What? Jack turned to look at him. “What do you mean?”

“This dimension is shaped by our thoughts. And Taweret sent over a dozen of Apophis's slaves over. Slaves who considered him their god.” Daniel grimaced. “They might have *created* their god here.”

Jack blinked. That… made a lot of sense. But it also meant they were screwed.

“Fuck!” he spat.

*****

The Lost Dimension Part 3

Unknown Location, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Apophis was attacking Bright Moon! Adora took a step forward, brandishing her sword, before she registered Daniel's words. Turning to stare at him, she asked: "The slaves *created* Apophis here?"

"Ah, probably? We know that thoughts shape this dimension, and if over a dozen people believe Apophis is their god…" Daniel grimaced.

"But… could they create an entire Ha'tak?" Sha're asked.

"We don't know," Entrapta said. She was not looking at them or at the Ha'tak but staring at her tool. "In theory, anything is possible here - even the laws of nature might be changed through thought. But without testing, we don't know how much effort that takes." She finally looked at them. "Maybe if we try to change the world together?"

"Great. We'll defeat the enemy through the power of shared delusions," Jack muttered.

"Do you want to tackle a Ha'tak with your gun?" Glimmer shot back. "It doesn't look like this Bright Moon has any active defences that can take it, either."

She was right. Adora couldn't see any guns returning fire at the Ha'tak as it kept firing at the magic shield protecting the town. It looked like Bright Moon at the start of the Horde War.

"Other question!" Bow spoke up. "Why does this dimension look like Etheria?"

Adora blinked. That was a good question! The only person who knew Etheria in this dimension - before her friends and herself

had arrived - would be… “Catra!” Her lover was stubborn to a fault, wasn’t she? She might be able to create this.

“You think Catra imagined this?” Glimmer sounded sceptical.

“Who else could it be?” Adora asked.

“If it were Catra, why don’t we see Horde frigates pound Apophis’s ship to dust?” Jack asked.

Another good question.

“Look at the Whispering Woods!” Glimmer exclaimed. “That smoke…”

Entrapta lowered her visor and leaned forward. After a moment, she straightened. “That’s coming from Plumeria.”

Adora drew a sharp breath. So much smoke… the whole kingdom must be burning! Apophis! And now he was trying to destroy Bright Moon! “We have to stop him!”

“Unfortunately, I forgot to pack a frigate into my pocket,” Jack said.

“We could imagine one!” Bow said. “Just think about one appearing and blowing Apophis to bits!”

Adora immediately thought about a Horde frigate just doing that. One from… Second Fleet. Not Third Fleet. She didn’t need Priest here. Oh! “Make clear that it’s an allied Horde frigate!” she said. “Second Fleet!” Someone snickered, probably Jack, but she ignored it and just thought about a frigate from Second Fleet. One to defend this world against Apophis. To save everyone. Just a single frigate!

“I don’t think it’s working,” Jack said after a while. “Carter?”

“We don’t detect any substantial changes in the vicinity, sir. Or in orbit,” Sam replied. “If this Ha’tak was the result of a shared

conviction by Apophis's slaves that he was their god and would arrive, then it might take several weeks to show such a significant change - and we have fewer people here than were sent to this dimension by Taweret."

So, it wouldn't work! Adora gritted her teeth. "Then we have to get into the ship and just defeat him!"

"Oh!" Glimmer disappeared and reappeared a moment later in front of Adora. She smiled a little sheepishly. "I almost forgot to check - magic works here! I can teleport us inside!"

That was great news! Adora beamed at her friend.

"But can you teleport us all inside? And off again, should Apophis suddenly decide to blow up his own ship and escape?" Jack asked. "Or display whatever god-like powers his slaves think he should have?"

Right. "Just get me on the ship. I can take him," Adora said. She had defeated Horde Prime. She could take Apophis.

"Are you sure?" Bow asked. "We don't know how strong this Apophis is."

"Yes." She had to do it. She had to stop Apophis before he destroyed Bright Moon here.

"Ah. Shouldn't we try to contact the locals first and coordinate?" Daniel said. "And find out why this dimension looks like Etheria?"

Adora pressed her lips together. The longer they waited, the greater the risk that the shield failed. The Horde had almost broken it once through continuous bombardment. And they hadn't had the firepower of a Ha'tak.

"If there's another She-Ra here…" Bow trailed off, and Glimmer nodded. "Yes. Let's go to Bright Moon. I can teleport us there!"

"All of us?" Jack asked again.

“I can recharge at the Runestone,” Glimmer said.

“Shouldn’t the stone be linked to the local Queen?” Sam sounded surprised.

“I can recharge there even without being linked to it,” Glimmer said. “As I did before I became Queen of Bright Moon.” She held out her hands. “Let’s go!”

“Ah… we should make sure that they don’t mistake us for attackers,” Daniel said. “We are strangers - and you might be mistaken for, ah, doppelgangers.”

Oh. Adora clenched her teeth. Being mistaken for Double-Trouble would be bad indeed. “We’ll have to be careful.”

“I can demonstrate my power,” Glimmer said. “Double-Trouble can’t copy that. And if I have a double there, she’ll listen to us if she’s anything like me.”

Ah. Adora exchanged a glance with Bow. It seemed he didn’t share their friend’s confidence either.

But she didn’t think they had a choice - the shield wouldn’t last forever.

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Samantha Carter wouldn’t say she was easily impressed, not after everything she had seen, but this dimension was *incredible*. It looked like Etheria - or, rather, the region of Bright Moon, the Whispering Woods and Plumeria; she hadn’t seen the other regions yet - and yet, the resemblance was only superficial. Her instruments and sensors showed differences that made it very obvious that they were in a dimension where the laws of nature differed significantly from her home dimension. Not a parallel dimension or universe at all.

Sure, she had known that from the sensor readings she had seen back at Alpha, but the difference between seeing the data and

actually experiencing it in person was stark.

"Oh! I think we're starting to affect the dimension!" Entrapta said next to her as they waited for Glimmer to return. "Look!" Her hair turned her multitool towards Sam.

Sam glanced at it. "The tree changed density… far faster than would be possible."

"Yes! I imagined it being less dense, and it started to change!" Entrapta beamed. "We can change the world!"

They could. In very small ways, so far, but to think that reality - this dimension's reality - was theirs to change on a whim… It was a daunting prospect, but Sam couldn't help feeling excited. The possibilities were endless! They could create the perfect environment for an experiment. No - the nature of the dimension would preclude running experiments since their expectations would absolutely affect the outcome. But they could create environments that would offer the exact effects they wanted for any given task.

Well, they could once they had dealt with Apophis, Sam reminded herself, feeling a little foolish, when she heard another rolling barrage of blast cannon fire hit the magic shield in the distance. She should focus on that problem instead of getting distracted. On the other hand, to defeat Apophis, they needed all the data about this dimension that they could get.

"Alright! I'll take us inside the palace!" Glimmer announced. "Adora! Bow!"

Both reached out, and a moment later, all three disappeared in a cloud of sparks.

"I really hope that the shield keeps holding up," the General muttered. "Or this will be the shortest rescue mission in Alliance history."

“The readings we took show that while it is degrading, it’s a linear process and, barring any significant changes, it will take at least another hour to reach the point of collapse - though there’s a bit of guesswork involved when that point arrives - we never got the data we need to calculate it precisely,” Entrapta announced.

“That’s very reassuring,” the General replied.

“I know!” Entrapta beamed at him, completely missing his sarcasm.

Sam frowned at him, and he had the grace to look sheepish.

“Well, one hour should be…”

Glimmer’s arrival cut Daniel off. “Alright. I’ve dropped Adora and Bow off. Entrapta! Sam!”

Sam took her hand, Entrapta latched onto the other, and then Sam’s stomach twisted a little as Glimmer used her power.

A moment later, they were standing in one of the courtyards of the palace - and facing several guards.

“Princess! Wait!” the officer in charge yelled.

“No time!” Glimmer replied - and disappeared again.

Sam wasn’t as skilled as Daniel in such matters, but this wasn’t the best way to enter a foreign nation’s seat of government. Especially a seat that was currently under attack - she could see and hear the Ha’tak’s guns hit the shield above her, a constant, unnerving sequence of impacts and explosions. If the shield suddenly collapsed…

“Who are you?” the officer turned to frown at Sam.

“That’s my other science buddy, Sam!” Entrapta told him. “Hi!”

“Major Samantha Carter,” she informed him. “Alliance Military.”

“Alliance Military?” He looked confused.

“Not the Princess Alliance - not yours,” Adora told him. “Ours.”

“But…”

Once again, Glimmer appeared, dropping off the Daniel and Sha’re.

“Princess!”

And she was gone.

“Ah… Hello?” Daniel smiled at the guards.

“Let’s just wait until all of us are here,” Bow said. “Then we can explain. OK?”

To Sam’s surprise, the guards seemed to accept that. She would have thought they would be more suspicious - or on edge - during an attack on the palace.

But then Glimmer returned with the General and Teal’c and all but collapsed, panting. “That… took a bit more out of me than I thought,” she managed to say as she bent over.

“Princess!”

“Glimmer!”

“Glimmer? Adora? What are you doing here? Entrapta? Bow? Why did you return?”

Sam had never met the woman standing in the doorway behind the guards, but she recognised her immediately.

“Mom?”

“Angella?”

Queen Angella. Glimmer's mother. Sam pressed her lips together while Adora and Glimmer gasped and paled. They should have considered that this Bright Moon was still ruled by Queen Angella. How this would affect Glimmer, Sam didn't know, but it would surely complicate matters.

"Ah… we can explain," Bow said, grimacing.

"We're not from this dimension," Entrapta spoke up. "We're from another dimension. And we're here to help. And to save Catra. And to gather data!"

Sometimes, Entrapta's bluntness could be very helpful. Sam hoped that this would be one of those times.

Angella had gone pale as well. "Glimmer?" She sounded… hesitating, not doubtful, Sam noticed.

Glimmer grimaced. "I'm from another dimension. I'm not your Glimmer," she said.

"Your daughter and our, ah, counterparts are still… wherever they are, I guess, Your Majesty," Bow said. "And… ah, these are our friends. Allies. General O'Neill, Major Carter, Doctor Jackson, Sha're. Teal'c."

Angella barely glanced at him and ignored the others. She kept staring at Glimmer instead as if she were shocked to see her.

"So…" Adora started to say after an awkward moment but was interrupted by a particularly loud impact on the shield.

"I don't want to alarm anyone," the General said, "but how much longer is the shield going to last?"

"It will last long enough for Adora and the others to return with She-Ra's ship," Angella stated.

She sounded confident, but Sam checked the data from their sensors anyway. It showed some degradation of the shield,

although at a stable and very slow rate. Still, it wouldn't last forever - at this rate, it would collapse in a bit over six hours.

“Oh! You're recovering Darla?” Entrapta beamed. “Do you need help? I've restored Darla before - and we modified her once; we can do it again! Although we might not have the time to do that before the shield falls here,” she added, biting her lower lip.

And even with upgrades, Darla didn't have the firepower to shoot down a Ha'tak, Sam knew. She could outfly it, of course, and a hit-and-run strategy might prove effective in some circumstances, but Bright Moon couldn't run. And that was based on the known capabilities of a Ha'tak in their home dimension. They didn't know what this Ha'tak could do.

“I can teleport us inside the Ha'tak,” Glimmer said. She was still glancing at Angella even as she addressed the others. “Once we're inside, we can take out Apophis - and we can sabotage his ship.” She straightened. “But I'll need your permission to recharge from the runestone for that. Your Majesty,” she added after a moment with a weak smile. “I'm kind of exhausted right now.”

Angella tensed at the address. “It's too dangerous to enter the enemy ship like that.”

“It's our best chance!” Glimmer retorted. “We have done this before.”

“Not against an actual god,” Daniel pointed out.

“Apophis is a false god,” Teal'c objected.

“Not in this dimension,” Daniel retorted. “We don't know how powerful this Apophis is.”

“It doesn't hurt to try!” Glimmer said, then blinked. “I mean… It could hurt, of course, but we've done this before, without magic.”

“Glimmer!” Angella snapped. “The ship is protected!”

“Not against magic!” Glimmer retorted.

“Actually…” Daniel winced when both women turned to glare at him. “Our Apophis couldn't protect himself against magic, as far as we know. But this Apophis?”

“Let me try! What do we have to lose?” Glimmer said.

“Your life!” Angella spat. “And the shield does repel magic attacks. We tried that.”

“What kind of magic attacks did you try?” Entraptra asked.

“Everything we could,” Angella replied with a frown. “We couldn't stop it. We couldn't even slow down its approach.”

That didn't tell them much. In order to estimate this Ha'tak's capabilities - and weaknesses - they needed more information.

But before Sam or Entrapta could ask for details, Adora spoke up. “Ah. As Entrapta said, we're looking for a friend of ours - our Catra. Have you seen her?”

Angella tensed again and looked at Adora with a frown. This time, Sam was sure that it wasn't a good sign.

*****

The constant barrage was unnerving. Even in her cell, Catra could hear every impact against the magic shield protecting Bright Moon, and there were a lot of them. Probably more than during the Horde attack, which had almost brought it down in her dimension, and that had taken most of the artillery parks of an entire front and strained the logistics of the Fright Zone. Apophis obviously didn't have to worry about that.

Maybe I should escape, Catra thought, not for the first time. If the shield fell, then the force fields holding her captive in her new cell wouldn't last a second. Unfortunately, her odds of escaping a second time weren't good - unlike her first cell, this cell had force

fields covering the roof and floor as well. And they were claw-proof. Although Catra hadn't gone all out. Even though her claws might not be able to scratch the force fields, if she applied enough force…

Her ears twitched as she picked up voices. Familiar voices.

"...can't believe you locked her up!"

Adora? Catra blinked. But this Adora was supposed to recover Darla. Was she back already?

"She was the Horde leader."

And that was Angella. But why was she saying this? Adora had been the one to put Catra into this cell before leaving for Darla. Why would…

Her eyes widened as she heard more people. More familiar people. Jack, Sam, Daniel…

She gasped and jumped up, pressing herself against the force field facing the door. Her Adora was here! And her friends! They had come for her! They hadn't abandoned her!

She drew back and straightened just in time for the door to open, then flashed a grin.

"Hey, Adora."

"Catra!"

Adora's face lit up with so much relief - and love - that Catra swallowed her comment about how it had taken Adora long enough to find her and just smiled and nodded. And blinked so her eyes would clear up.

A moment later, Adora was pressed against the force field, and Catra could almost *feel* her lover's eyes go over her body, searching for any signs of wounds or bruises.

“I'm fine,” she told her.

“You're locked up!” Adora protested. “In a cell!”

“She was the leader of the Horde,” Catra heard Angella protest.

“Was. She joined the alliance,” Adora replied before turning to look at the queen. “Let her out now!”

Angella hesitated for a moment, and Catra saw her frown at her and glance at Glimmer before she pushed a button on the wall to deactivate the force field.

And then Adora's arms wrapped around Catra, and they embraced. And kissed.

And Catra relaxed with a shuddering breath. Adora was back with her. They were together again. For a moment, she didn't hear or feel the impacts from Apophis's barrage. Didn’t think about their situation, this dimension. Just held Adora.

Someone cleared their throat.

Catra ignored them.

Someone cleared their throat again.

Catra still ignored them.

“So, that’s the second time we had to save the cat, huh?”

With a scowl, Catra pulled back from Adora and released her - mostly. She kept an arm wrapped around Adora's side and her tail brushing over Adora's leg. “I could have escaped any time,” she told Glimmer. “I actually did, and only came back to save… them,” she finished with a glance at Angella. The queen was alone with them in the room, she noticed - no guards were present. No locals were here at all.

Interesting.

“Sure you could have teleported through the force fields here,” Glimmer retorted, shaking her head. She was smiling, which took the sting out of her comments, but Catra didn’t miss how she kept sneaking glances at Angella. Right. She should have expected this. After losing her mother, meeting another Angella would shake up Glimmer.

So, Catra let the matter drop and didn't mention her options to get out of the cell - mostly centred on luring the guards to lower the force field to get the drop on them. Besides, it was best to keep that a secret, just in case.

“Any news from the recovery mission?” she asked instead.

Angella narrowed her eyes at her. “They have found the ship and are in the process of repairing it.”

“Darla. She has a name,” Entrapta objected before blinking. “Well, our Darla was named Darla. You probably should ask her if she wants a different name.”

“Ships are female,” Jack added with a grin.

“Actually, that's not a universal custom,” Daniel cut in. “The Russians, for example, use a male gender while in German, a neutral gender is used.”

“I don't think the gender of the ship in question is important,” Jack said. Daniel opened his mouth, likely to point out that Jack started it, but Jack cut him off. “What's important is whether or not the ship can get us inside Apophis's floating palace.”

“It should,” Catra said. “It's only a Ha'tak.” Horde Prime's flagship would be different, but Darla's shields should be able to get them through a Ha'tak's protections. She wasn't a scientist, but she knew the capabilities of both ships by heart. She had to, to make proper tactical decisions and plans.

“Ah, we actually don't know that,” Daniel said with a weak smile. “That this is a normal Ha'tak, I mean.”

Catra narrowed her eyes. “It looks and shoots like a normal one,” she said.

“Yes, but it was created by the thoughts of the slaves of Apophis displaced to this dimension. They consider him a god,” Daniel explained. “So, depending on their imagination, we could be dealing with a literal divine vessel.”

Catra blinked. What was he saying? “The slaves created the ship?” she asked out loud. That was insane!

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “Well, that's our hypothesis, but the sensor readings we took looking for you and the data we have of this dimension support it. This dimension is affected by the minds of its inhabitants. Or shaped - it's very malleable; even the laws of nature here aren’t fixed. It's one of the most interesting places we've ever seen! Can you imagine living in a dimension where you can alter reality with your imagination?”

Catra couldn't help thinking that sometimes, Entrapta looked rather scary, in a deranged way. This was one of those times. If they were a dimension defined and altered by your imagination… She gasped and stared at Angella, then back at her friends. “Do you mean that not just the ship but Apophis himself might have been created by those people Taweret sent here?”

Entrapta nodded.

“That's our running hypothesis,” Sam confirmed. “We noticed a massive change in the dimension's structure, and it seems to correlate with the Ha'tak's appearance, although we have yet to confirm it.”

“So, we're fighting a god imagined by his brainwashed followers?” Catra shook her head. A dimension where people could create a god just by believing in them? Wait! Did that mean… “Can anyone do this? Imagine a god? Or other people?” she interrupted Sam’s explanation about how time might play a role, and the

accumulation of like-minded individuals or whatever affected the process.

“Ah… theoretically, yes,” Sam told her.

“The only theoretical limits are your imagination!” Entrapta added. “It's so fascinating!”

Catra felt her stomach drop. You could create people by thinking of them? And your only limits were your imagination? Or… your knowledge? It would explain a lot. She turned to glance at Angella. The queen was glaring at her, but also… nervous? Catra shook her head. This was a bad idea, but… she had to know. Had to ask.

“Did you create all of this?” She gestured at the room. “Bright Moon, Etheria? The people here?”

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What did she mean by that? Jack O'Neill tensed and glanced at Catra, then at Angella. The queen had frozen for a moment, and he felt his stomach drop.

“What?” Adora asked, sounding confused.

Angella was still not saying anything, just staring at Catra.

And Catra was staring straight back. “Angella isn't from this dimension.”

“What?” Half the room blurted out the same question.

Angella didn't deny it, Jack couldn't help noting. Though her stare turned into a glare.

And Entrapta was already running with it. “Well… that is a new theory. We thought that the dimension's native inhabitants - sapient inhabitants - had formed a meta-consensus that allowed them to stabilise a core part of the dimension thanks to a shared

view of how reality should work. And we thought that this would likely be a sort of hive-mind, though that was speculation based on human mental structures. But if this stabilised area was the result of one mind… it could work. We already know that there's a temporal component to the shaping effect, and if you had enough time, you could likely influence a significant part of the dimension, especially if there were no other minds attempting to shape it. And! It would explain why this dimension looks so much like Etheria! The odds that the natives of this dimension would form a world like ours despite the drastic differences in how the dimension works were pretty much zero, now that I think of it. I should have thought of that myself, but I was distracted by the new dimension's data. Sorry!”

Jack blinked. He wasn’t a scientist, but he was used to listening to them, and that sounded like Entrapta thought this was a valid theory.

He glanced at Carter, who slowly nodded. “It would explain several things we noticed,” she said.

“But…” Adora looked around, then settled on Catra. “How do you know that?”

“We talked,” Catra told her without looking away from Angella. “She told me. This is Etheria how you think it should have been, huh?”

Angella still didn't answer, but Jack could see she was starting to scowl at Catra. He clenched his teeth. The last thing they wanted was a blow-out between them and the queen - and possible creator - of this land right in the middle of a Goa'uld attack.

“But… if you're not from this dimension, where are you from?” Glimmer asked, almost hesitantly.

Jack swallowed a curse. It didn't take a genius to realise what she was thinking, hoping, right now.

Angella turned to look at Glimmer, and her expression softened somewhat. “I came from Etheria - my Etheria. I stepped through a portal, sacrificing myself to save it.” She narrowed her eyes, scowled at Catra and spat: “A portal she opened to conquer Etheria!”

Catra flinched at that and seemed to shrink in herself.

Ouch, Jack thought.

“She changed!” Adora spoke up, wrapping her arm around Catra's shoulders. “We all did. We made peace with the Horde - and we defeated Horde Prime together. And now we're fighting Apophis and the other Goa'ulds. Together.”

Right. Couldn't forget the snake trying to kill them all. The snake that was potentially a god-like snake thanks to a bunch of brainwashed slaves.

Angella didn't take that well. “She almost destroyed Etheria, and you forgive her?”

“I thought forgiving was the thing on Etheria,” Jack said before he could stop himself. He didn't flinch when Angella glared at him, though. She might be queen of a land she had created and have magic powers, but… well… in for a penny, in for a pound. He shrugged. “People can change. Teal'c was Apophis's First Prime before he defected, saving us all.”

“Indeed.” Teal'c, of course, just inclined his head in his usual way when Angella turned to glare at him.

“The Horde seems to have settled in well, the clones working hard to fight the snakes,” he went on. No need to go into details.

“And Hordak threw off Horde Crime's mind control!” Entrapta contributed.

“Hordak!” Angella hissed. “You are allied with *him*?”

Right. He had been the main enemy of hers, hadn't she?

“People can change!” Adora said, not letting go of Catra, and Jack resisted the sudden impulse to add ‘for better or worse’. This was a very delicate situation, but if they could defuse this and focus on defeating the freshly created Apophis II…

“Are… are you *our* Angella?” Glimmer asked in a very soft voice that still made everyone tense up again. She moved her mouth, adding something in a whisper that Jack didn't catch.

And Angella drew a sharp breath and closed her eyes before slowly turning to face Glimmer. “I… I don't know.” Shaking her head, she added: “I don't know any of you. I don't understand how you could… be like that.”

“Uh…” Bow grimaced when most people looked at him. “If you're not from our dimension, then something should show up on a scan… I think. But we probably need better instruments to tell.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded emphatically. “Since no universe is exactly the same, there should be discernible differences even between parallel universes with closely-matching history. If we get enough data, we should find them!” With a frown, she added: “Although proving that you're from the same universe would be a bit harder, since even if we don't find any differences, we could not really be sure that we just lacked the instruments to find them. We don't have a lot of data on multi-dimensional differences.”

“And we don't have a lot of time to deal with Apophis,” Jack cut in. This was all getting far too technical or philosophical for him. They were still under constant bombardment, for crying out loud! “So, let’s focus on that? We can sort out the rest afterwards.”

At least, he hoped so. In any case, you had to be alive to sort things out.

*****

Angella had created this world? This area of the dimension they were in, Adora corrected herself. It was incredible, but she trusted her friends. And Angella hadn't denied it. And she was not from this dimension, either. So, she could even be their Angella - the one who had sacrificed herself to seal the portal, saving Etheria from destruction. And Adora from sacrificing herself.

Glimmer's mom.

Adora desperately wanted to find out if this was true. She wasn't sure, though, if she wanted to find out what it meant for the people they had seen - guards she knew back home. And Catra… she had to talk to Catra. Her lover was shaken by this; she was putting up a good front, but Adora could tell.

But Jack was right - they had to stop Apophis first.

She nodded. "Glimmer needs to recharge at the runestone. And we need to know if we can get inside the ship with magic."

"It's protected against magic," Angella said.

"Did you try teleportation magic? Did this dimension's…" Glimmer trailed off, and Adora saw she was clenching her teeth.

"That would have been too dangerous to attempt," Angella retorted.

"So, you didn't let her." Glimmer scowled. "I'll try it!"

"No!" Angella blurted out.

"You can't stop me!" Glimmer spat.

"I won't let you recharge!"

"Well, they don't really act like family," Catra mumbled next to Adora.

Adora pressed her lips together. Catra had never seen it, but Glimmer and Angella were acting exactly as they had during the Horde war. "We need to know. If we can teleport inside, we won't have to risk a boarding action."

"And we won't have to wait for Darla to be recovered," Bow added.

"The shield will hold," Angella said. "I know it."

"Because you want it to hold?" Catra asked in a clipped tone. "You alone, against a god imagined by over a dozen people?"

Angella glared at her. "It will hold."

"Uh… Your Majesty, what exactly did you do with the people sent here before us and Catra?" Daniel said before Catra could push Angella some more.

"Adora collected them before they could get lost, and we put them in a small village in Bright Moon."

"Near the border to Plumeria?" Glimmer asked.

"Where the Ha'tak appeared?" Catra added

"Yes," Angella said, pointedly looking at Glimmer, not at Catra.

"Did Apophis pick them up?" Jack asked.

Angella frowned. "I don't know. We were focusing on evacuating the villages in the ship's path and trying ways to attack it."

"Would Apophis really have left his faithful?" Bow asked. "They're the source of his power."

"He might not be aware of that," Glimmer retorted.

"But they might imagine their god taking them with him, and so that is what a god created by them would do," Bow pointed out.

That made sense to Adora. But that didn't mean it was true - religion seldom made sense in her experience. However, she also had to admit that she was a little biased there.

"They also know that Apophis is a cruel god," Jack said. "They built his secret base, and as a reward, he got rid of them and let Taweret use them for experiments."

"That doesn't mean that they would have lost their faith in him." Daniel shook his head. "Many religious people are perfectly capable of finding explanations and excuses for their deity letting them suffer even though they should be able to help them. The former slaves could think this was a test of their faith. Or that they had failed Apophis or disobeyed him, and this was their punishment."

"What if he killed them with his bombardment? Wouldn't that, uh, unmake himself?" Jack asked.

"Eventually, probably," Sam replied after a moment. "But changes aren't instantaneous here, and we have not observed the constant changes you'd expect if the reality was reacting at once to any stray thought - or to the creator of the change falling asleep. So, there has to be a stabilising effect. Even if the people who thought up this Apophis were dead, I would think the Ha'tak would not be affected for several hours, or even longer."

"So, no killing the slaves to kill Apophis," Catra said. She was grinning, but Adora had a feeling that at least a few people here wouldn't have been joking about this.

"What would happen if we left, and Apophis would end up alone with his slaves here?" Sha're asked. "Would he or his faithful be able to find a way to reach our dimension?"

That was a very good question, in Adora's opinion.

"You mean if we all left?" Daniel looked at her.

Sha're nodded.

If Apophis were trapped here, could he escape? But could they leave everyone except for Angella? If the people here were just imaginary people… Adora shook her head. "We would have to rescue the former slaves as well."

Catra scoffed but didn't contradict her.

"Mission creep."

"Jack! We always planned to save everyone!" Daniel protested.

"Sometimes, that is impossible," Teal'c commented.

"We're not leaving anyone behind," Adora said. Never again. "We'll destroy the Ha'tak and Apophis." She looked at Angella again. "We need to test Glimmer's power against the Ha'tak's defences."

Angella jerked a little as if she had been struck, and Adora felt guilty for asking this.

But Glimmer nodded. "Yes."

And she and Angella were staring at each other again. At least they weren't shouting, though.

*****

Samantha Carter half-expected Glimmer to yell 'you're not my mom!' at Angella. Despite the seriousness of the situation - they were under constant bombardment, and the magic shield would not last forever - the confrontation between the two queens left an impression of a family spat on her.

Which hinted at implications Sam didn't want to go in right now. Not when they had an Apophis powered by faith to defeat. And speaking of that… "We need to test something else," she said, interrupting the confrontation. "We need to know if anything taken from this dimension will last in our dimension."

“Oh, yes!” Entrapta was quick to agree. “We cannot exclude the possibility that this Apophis could create a way to travel dimensions - it's actually quite likely since the people believing in him were transported across dimensions, so they know it's possible - but we don't know if anything created here - or anyone - could survive in another dimension where the laws of nature are different. It depends on the exact properties of the way things are created here. If you think something into existence, does that create something permanent that won't change again unless there's someone else influencing it, or is anything here just the base energy, sort of, of this dimension, and without thoughts stabilising it, it will return to its base form? The lingering effect we theorised would indicate it would last at least for some time, but we don’t have any exact data!” She beamed. “But! We can find out. We just need to call Hordak and then have him transport something from here back.”

“We need to be very careful, though,” Sam quickly cautioned. “If the matter taken from here returns to energy almost instantaneously, the consequences could be drastic. Explosive,” she added for those who didn't immediately catch the implications.

The General winced. “If Apophis here could send nukes over to our dimension by chucking rocks through a gate, that could be a bit of a problem,” he said with a twisted grin.

Adora nodded with a firm impression. “It doesn’t matter. We'll stop him here anyway and save everyone.” She looked at Entrapta, Bow and Sam. “Set up a safe way to test it while Glimmer recharges.”

Sam saw Angella stiffen, but to her surprise, the queen didn't object. And Glimmer didn't gloat but looked at Bow. “Bow?”

“Ah, I'll stay here - we need to know what happens if we take stuff from here back,” Bow said with an apologetic smile.

Glimmer nodded, and she left with Adora, Angella and Catra.

“Alright! I'll call Hordak and check where we can dump a potentially huge bomb without destroying anything important!” Entrapta announced.

“And we'll gather an appropriate sample,” Sam said. Small enough so the potential energy was manageable.

“I'll prepare a sensor suite for the transport.” Bow took out his tools. “So we don’t need to use fixed sensors.”

Which meant they could use a greater distance from the planet as the arrival point and still get all the data they needed. Sam nodded and looked around in the yard. Any rock would do, but something more complex might be more useful. Although anything complex would be big enough to pose a substantial risk should it explode.

Best start with a rock, then scale it up to more complex devices if the first experiment went well. And then try it with animals.

Sam didn't add ‘and then with people’, not even in the privacy of her head. Not even if those people might just be figments of Angella's imagination.

Five minutes later, everything was ready. A small rock rested in a box Bow had put together, surrounded by a sensor suite, and Entrapta had finished coordinating with Hordak.

“Alright! Hordak says the target area is clear. And that he has a lock on the beacon, though we should evacuate the area anyway so none of us gets caught up in the effect. That would be bad without a spacesuit,” she said.

Sam nodded, suppressing a wince, and they retreated out of the courtyard, leaving the box on a small support made from material from their own dimension.

“Go-time!” Entrapta announced.

A moment later, the area around the box warped - and it was gone, with the support.

Sam immediately turned to her laptop, set up in the room next to the yard. The communication lag meant it would take a few seconds for the data to arrive. They felt like hours.

Then the data came back. The rock was stable. Sam drew a breath through clenched teeth. That meant they didn't have to fear a barrage of transdimensional nukes from a victorious imaginary Apophis. And that the air in their lungs was safe as well - replacing that with air from home would have been a bother.

But it also meant that Apophis could form an army here and invade another dimension if his creations lasted at least a little while. And it opened ethical questions about this world's people. What would happen to them if Angella left? Would they stay or fade into energy? And what if by transporting them to another dimension, they could become stable? Could they leave them to fade away if they could save them?

More data came in.

“Oh! It looks like there's some small degradation of the rock's structural integrity,” Entrapta said. “It's losing mass.”

“It could fade?” Bow asked. He sounded happy about it.

Even though she felt guilty for it, Sam shared his feelings. That was one potential very messy problem avoided.

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The Lost Dimension Part 4

Unknown Location, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Standing near the huge recharging station below the runestone - Glimmer didn't like that name, but it *was* a recharger - Catra and the others were waiting until Glimmer finished recharging. Angella, too, was standing here - after dropping Glimmer off above.

Catra kept her distance from the queen. Whether this was the Angella from Catra's home dimension - or universe; the differences weren't quite clear to her - the woman had created the entire world here, and if that was her dream world, then it was obvious that she had issues. Wiping out the entire Horde… Catra suppressed a shudder. And this Angella had had Catra imprisoned even though Catra had returned to help save the world. Talk about carrying a grudge!

But that was moot now. Adora, the real Adora, was here. Had come to save her! Catra smiled as she leaned into her love. "Missed you," she whispered.

"Missed you too," Adora whispered back.

Catra didn't miss how Angella stiffened. She almost smirked. It must hurt to realise that the copy you had imagined wasn't even close to the original. The real Adora was so much more than She-Ra. And she loved Catra! "I hope that won't take long," she said.

"She needs to recharge fully," Angella said - without looking at them; Catra checked. "It's foolhardy to attempt this at all; it would be suicidal to do so without having fully restored her power."

"Glimmer can do it!" Adora said. "We've been through worse!"

Catra had her doubts - they were dealing with a Goa'uld turned into a real god, or what the slaves thought a real god was - but kept silent. This was not her world or dimension, and if thoughts

could change the world here, then she couldn't damage Adora's trust in Glimmer.

Though with Angella herself being so pessimistic… Catra clenched her teeth. "Yes, Glimmer can do it. This Apophis was created by people who grew up without magic and won't know what it can do." And what you didn't know, you couldn't counter or stop.

Angella winced, and Catra grimaced. "Don't tell me… You gave them lessons?"

The queen glared at her as if this was Catra's fault. "When we found and saved the first arrival, we welcomed them - and showed them Etheria."

"And magic." Catra sighed softly. And refrained from making a comment about the fact everyone here was a creation of Angella's imagination. There was no real 'we' here to speak of for the queen.

"And magic." Angella scowled. "And this is how they repaid our hospitality: By launching an attack on us with their imaginary god!"

An imaginary god attacking an imaginary world, Catra thought but - once again - didn't say. She couldn't help glancing back, though, at the guards lined up at the end of the bridge leading here. Imaginary people. The whole world was just… made up. Created according to the desire of Angella. Her perfect world.

Catra felt her fur bristle at the thought.

Glimmer appeared in a cloud of sparkles in front of them. "Done!" she announced. Her smile faded as she glanced from Adora and Catra at Angella.

The queen straightened. "I have to, once again, caution you against this. The risks are too high, and it is not necessary. Soon, Glimmer and the others will have restored She-Ra's ship and return to take down this false god."

Glimmer clenched her teeth, and for a moment, Catra's ears picked up a low whining noise from her. But then Glimmer raised her chin and spoke in a prim and proper tone. "We cannot trust that everything works out with Darla - or that she will be able to penetrate the Ha'tak's defences. Any good plan needs contingencies to withstand the test of the battlefield."

Angella deeply frowned at that, and Glimmer's lips moved into a hint of a smug smile. She probably had quoted her mother here.

If this Angella was actually their Angella - Glimmer's mother - things would become very awkward back home. And not just because Glimmer was now queen of Bright Moon. Had been queen for years, actually. But the family dynamics… "Poor Micah," she whispered.

"What?" Adora turned to look at her.

"Nothing," Catra said.

Glimmer and Angella continued to stare at each other for a second before Glimmer turned away. "Alright. I'll test if I can get into the Ha'tak. Assemble the others - if I can do it, I'll get back at once and take you up!"

"Alright. Let's go to the yard," Adora said.

Catra nodded. "Yes. Better not try anything so close to the recharger."

Glimmer frowned at her - as did Angella - but she didn't care. It was a recharging station.

Five minutes and an explanation about how stuff taken from here would fade back home from Entrapta later, they were ready.

Glimmer hugged Bow, glanced at Angella again, then nodded and turned to look at the Ha'tak. It was still firing all its guns - Catra hadn't noticed any of them slowing down or falling silent. Of course, imaginary ships never suffered malfunctions…

“I’ll be back!” Glimmer announced, then disappeared.

A moment later, Catra saw a flash above the Ha’tak that wasn’t a gun firing. She hissed and squinted - there was a speck falling towards the ship - no, towards the ground. Damn!

But then the speck disappeared, and Glimmer reappeared in front of them, falling to her knees. She was panting and looked roughed up. “I couldn’t get through the Ha’tak’s shields,” she said with a deep scowl as Bow embraced her.

“Guess we’re back to Plan Darla,” Catra said. Imaginary Darla.

Damn.

*****

Jack O’Neill had suspected that it wouldn’t work. The easy plans never worked. Something always came up that prevented you from just going in and shooting the bad guy. Well, mostly. Sometimes, stuff came up afterwards. But if teleporting didn’t work, there were other options. “So, we need a spaceship. Any chance that we can get one from home?”

Carter shook her head. “Unfortunately, sir, the dimensional portal projector can’t manage the mass of a space-capable craft. It would be destroyed by the attempt, as the data from Beta has shown.”

Jack had known that. But it never hurt to ask - sometimes, scientists forgot to mention things. Even Carter. “Would have been nice to call in a frigate.”

“We don’t know if a frigate is enough to deal with this Ha’tak,” Bow said. “It was created here and is resistant to magic. It might be more powerful than a Horde frigate.”

Jack frowned. “And yet we’ll place our hope on Darla II.”

“She won’t let us down!” Entrapta said. “Especially if we overhaul her!”

“We might not have time for that,” Bow pointed out. He glanced up at the shield above them.

Jack looked up as well. He might be mistaken, but the flashes from the impact of the Ha’tak’s cannons seemed to have grown stronger - or the shield had grown weaker.

“Even without an overhaul, Darla will get us through.” Entrapta showed no fear at all.

“Let’s hope so,” Jack said. If the shield started to fail, they would leave. That would leave Apophis in charge of this dimension, but they could and would return as soon as possible - and better prepared.

“Yes,” Daniel said. He didn’t look quite as worried as Jack expected. Something must have shown on his face since Daniel nodded. “It’s a different dimension, Jack. Belief matters here - probably more than anything else. Darla here is not merely an Ancient ship but also likely the embodiment of the hope of the world - she is She-Ra’s ship.”

Adora winced at that, Jack noticed. She didn’t say anything, though.

Catra, on the other hand, snorted. “The hope of a world created by a single person. Against a god created by a dozen faithful.”

“Well… Angella has been here for years,” Carter retorted. “If our theory is correct, if the impact of someone grows stronger with time, then she has left a lasting impact on the world, enough to outweigh the larger numbers of Apophis’s former slaves.”

If. Jack suppressed a wince.

“Angella didn’t imagine a god - or goddess - though,” Jack said.

“She imagined She-Ra, though,” Daniel said. “And from what we know, she saw She-Ra as the protector and saviour of the world. That adds a lot of power - probably.”

“I guess we’ll find out the hard way,” Catra said.

Jack nodded. The whole situation was weird - and making him uncomfortable. Sure, Napoleon had said that the moral was to the physical as three to one, but he didn’t mean people’s imagination. Wishes didn’t wars. Or shouldn’t. The universe shouldn’t work like that. It was unnatural. And he didn’t give a damn that it was natural in this dimension or whatever! Shrugging as casually as he managed, he said. “So, I guess we relax until the local She-Ra arrives with her ship.”

As if the snake had heard him, another volley hit a particularly close spot on the shield, and most in the courtyard glanced up worriedly.

“It’s not as if we can do anything else,” Catra said, scoffing slightly. “We can’t ‘direct the defence’.”

“It’s not our world,” Adora said - but with a glance towards the door leading into the palace, where the guards waited. And where Angella had gone to take command.

“It’s not much to direct, anyway,” Glimmer said. “Bright Moon has no way to strike back at the Ha’tak, so we can’t even prepare a sally.”

“You could prepare an evacuation,” Sha’re suggested.

“What for?” Catra snorted. “Angella is the only real person here, isn’t she?”

“Catra!” Adora hissed.

“What? She admitted that she created this world.”

“But that doesn’t mean that the people aren’t real. They act like… real people!” Adora objected.

“They don’t,” Catra disagreed. “You haven’t talked to them enough to tell, but they’re… more like bots. The way they talk. Dumb bots, not Emily,” she added.

“Ah.” Entrapta blinked, closed her mouth and nodded. “OK then.”

“But…” Adora trailed off. “We still can’t let them die!”

“Are they alive?” Catra shot back.

“That is an interesting question. Leaving biology aside - we can’t really use that given this dimension’s nature - and assuming they act like a bot, could they still be considered alive? Can they learn things? Evolve? If they are not people, could they become people?” Daniel shook his head. “Ethically, it’s a very difficult question.”

“You need to talk to this dimension’s Madam Razz,” Catra muttered. “She makes our Madam Razz sound like… Sam.”

“What do you mean?” Carter asked. She was a bit tense, Jack noted.

“Crisp, precise, smart,” Catra said. “This dimension’s Madam Razz sounds like a dumb bot with bad programming.”

Entrapta perked up. “Oh! Do you think we can fix that? Usually, we couldn’t, since they’re not really bots, but since we can change them with our thoughts, it should be possible, theoretically, to change them.”

“I think our presence is altering the world here,” Carter said.

Jack knew an evasion if he saw it. But he also knew that he didn’t want to make the entire mess even worse. And trying to change people or potential people was not going to help anyone, as far as he was concerned.

Before Carter could nip Entrapta’s plans in the bud, the door to the interior of the palace opened, and Angella stepped out. “Adora and the others called. They have recovered She-Ra’s ship and are returning.”

“Great!” Jack smiled. As dangerous as attacking a magical Ha’tak with a thousand-year-old small ship was, he much preferred that to discussing whether or not imaginary people were people.

*****

“There she is!”

Adora narrowed her eyes as she squinted after Catra's announcement. Yes, she could see Darla. Flying low - nap-of-the-earth flying, Jack called it - the ship rapidly approached. She craned her neck, trying to see if Death Gliders were closing in, but it seemed Apophis's troops had missed Darla. So far, at least. It wouldn't last forever.

She glanced around. Angella had chosen the ruins of Thaymor as the meeting spot since they couldn't have Darla land in Bright Moon while it was under attack. Angella had claimed Thaymor was the closest spot everyone knew, too far away for the Ha'tak's guns and an immediate strike from the Death Gliders but still close enough to be easily reached by Glimmer without exhausting herself again. Catra was sure it had been chosen because of her own actions in the Horde War, when she had destroyed the village and faced Adora as an enemy for the first time.

But this Thaymore had been rebuilt, like the one back home, but then destroyed by Apophis, so… Adora dropped the thought. This wasn't the time to worry about stuff like this. Not when they had an evil god to defeat.

And were about to meet their counterparts from this dimension. In the ruins of Thaymor. She winced. Maybe Angella had picked this meeting spot with that in mind? No - Angella knew how

important it was that everyone worked together. But she also had created the people they were about to meet.

She straightened as the ship touched down and the ramp opened. And tensed when she saw the people at the top of the ramp. Glimmer, Bow and Adora. They looked so young - like they hadn't aged since the early part of the war. This Adora was still wearing She-Ra's first uniform. And holding the original sword. The sword made by the First Ones to control the Heart of Etheria, Adora thought and clenched her teeth at the memories that brought up.

Glimmer - this dimension's Glimmer - started down the ramp. "Mom? Why did you call us here? Are you joining us in the…" she trailed off when she saw Adora and her friends. "What?"

"We have… allies from another universe," Angella told her.

"Allies? *Catra*?"

Adora winced at the loathing in her counterpart's tone. No, that wasn't her.

She felt Catra's tail wrap around her leg as her lover leaned into her side and flashed her fangs at this She-Ra. "Yes, as I told you before. Several times."

"That… that's a lie!" this She-Ra spat. "You're the enemy!" She glared at Catra - and then at Adora.

"Was the enemy. We're allies now," Catra retorted - and leaned into Adora's side.

"We don't have much time," Adora said before her counterpart could say anything else. "We need to stop Apophis before he breaks Bright Moon's shield. And we need to attack before he notices our ship."

"*My* ship!" the other She-Ra spat. "It's She-Ra's ship."

"Oh! You already enhanced the engines!" Entrapta exclaimed.

Adora turned to look at her friend and saw her held up by her hair tendrils, staring at the ship's engines through her visor.

Entrapta turned her head to look at the other trio. “Did you enhance the shields as well? We'll need them at full power to break through the Ha'tak's shields. At least according to my data.”

“Mom?” This dimension's Glimmer asked. “Are you sure about this?”

Angella nodded with a firm expression. It wasn't the kind of reassuring smile Adora had hoped to see. “Yes. Let us be off.”

“You're coming with us, Mom?”

“Yes.”

That was… Adora bit her lower lip. On the one hand, Angella being with them was good since the others would be listening to her. *She had created them, after all.* On the other hand, Angella coming with them would leave Bright Moon without its leader. And Angella had almost never been at the frontlines in the Horde War. Not while Adora had been in the Alliance. The only time Angella had fought directly had been… the day she had stepped into the portal to save Etheria.

“Yes, let's go. Not even his divine snakeness will miss a spaceship so close to his floating palace,” Jack spoke up.

“And who're you?” Glimmer said, frowning at him.

Enough! Adora took a step forward. “That's General Jack O'Neill. He's with our Alliance against the Goa'uld. And these are Major Samantha Carter…”

“My other science buddy!” Entrapta piped up.

“...Dr Daniel Jackson, Sha're and Teal'c,” Adora went on. “Teal'c defected from Apophis to our side,” she quickly added.

“Another ‘defector’?” the other She-Ra narrowed her eyes.

Teal'c didn't even flinch at her glare. “I oppose the false gods,” he said, tilting his head slightly.

“Sir! We've detected two Death Gliders headed towards us!” Sam announced.

“Time's up! Everyone on board!” Jack yelled.

“It's my ship!” The other She-Ra moved to block the ramp.

“Adora.” Angella smiled at her.

After a moment, the other She-Ra nodded and walked inside, followed by Angella.

“I can already tell that we'll be working well together,” Catra commented behind Adora as they quickly rushed up the ramp.

“Yeah, Apophis has already lost,” Jack agreed, his words dripping with as much sarcasm as Catra's.

“We'll pull through,” Adora said. But she wasn't quite sure. Catra had been right; their counterparts felt off. Weird.

Unnatural, Adora couldn't help thinking.

*****

“This is fascinating! It's like our Darla, and yet not! The interior is completely different!”

Because Angella only heard reports covering the ship’s appearance but never received any information about the interior of the vessel before she stepped through the portal, Samantha Carter thought as she and Entrapta followed the others to the bridge. Sam had to fight the urge to run and drag Entrapta with her, rushing after the rest of the group. This wasn't the Darla she

was familiar with; she wouldn't be able to do anything in the upcoming fight. She might make things worse, actually.

Potentially without doing anything, even. Would the ship adapt to their vision of Darla? They hadn't been in this dimension long enough to leave an imprint, at least as far as they knew. Certainly not long enough to effect major changes. Creating Apophis must have taken weeks to months. But smaller changes would be possible - if Catra had created Loo-Kee subconsciously, that would mean a few days were the threshold for sentient or sapient creatures.

Although there were many factors that they hadn't accounted for. Was it easier to create something new than to change something created by someone else? Did the creation's sapience or age matter? Or its power to affect the world?

"And those doors… they look more like the doors in Alpha than in Darla!" Entrapta ran a few hair tendrils over the door in the wall, prompting it to open as they stepped past, revealing a quite austere cabin.

Right. Angella had been born - or created - in the research base on the Third Moon of Enchantment, Sam reminded herself. She was familiar with Ancient architecture and technology - at least with its style.

The ship vibrated, then Sam heard the engine power up - they were taking off. "We should hurry," she said. "They will engage the Death Gliders soon." And Sam would rather be on the bridge for that. Even if she couldn't do anything, she wanted to see what was happening.

"Right! We'll be able to check how the weapons differ from ours!" Entrapta switched to walking using her hair, and the much longer steps quickly carried her ahead, forcing Sam to run.

The bridge didn't have enough seats for them - just the one for She-Ra, actually, Sam saw when they arrived a few seconds later.

Everyone else was standing. And they were already pulling high-g manoeuvres as the sight out the bridge windows showed; the inertial compensators were working better than she had expected.

“Oh, hello, Entrapta!”

“Oh? Hello!” And there was the second Entrapta, staring at them with a puzzled expression.

“Did you modify the engines?” Sam's Entrapta went on. “Or were they already different? How fast can they go?”

“We fixed them to the original specs - I didn't have enough time to modify them.”

“Oh! So the original specs differ as well!” Entrapta nodded. “Another difference between our worlds.”

“Death Gliders in range.” Bow interrupted them - this dimension's Bow, Sam reminded herself. He sounded tense.

“Shoot them down,” She-Ra ordered.

A moment later, Darla's guns fired, and both Death Gliders exploded.

The General whistled. “Good shooting!”

It was. Better than she had expected, Sam had to admit. This was the first time the locals were flying Darla in combat - their second time flying her at all - and scoring hits at that distance was not easy, even for an experienced crew. Though she couldn't tell if the guns were more or less powerful than the guns on Darla back home.

“Well done!” Angella nodded with a faint smile. “But those were just the first line. We need to board their flagship.”

“And we will!” She-Ra said with a grim expression.

“More Death Gliders incoming!”

“Shoot them down!”

The next engagement went as quickly as the first, the squadron of Death Gliders blown up in short order, and Darla flew on, towards the Ha'tak.

“Entering in range of the enemy's main guns!” Bow reported.

“Evasive manoeuvres!”

Once more, the inertial compensators worked perfectly. The ship was moving erratically, twisting and turning to evade the barrage from the Ha'tak, and yet Sam felt as if they were standing still. It was slightly disorienting.

Then a blast landed a glancing blow, and the shields flared up - and the ship lurched.

“That was close!”

“Shield holding!”

Sam glanced at the screens. How much had that taken out of their shield? She couldn't see the relevant data. How could you fight without that knowledge?

The enemy fire increased in volume as well, and more Death Gliders arrived. The Ha'tak in front of them was growing larger every second. Soon, they would hit the ship's shield…

“Open a hole!” She-Ra ordered.

Darla fired again, rapidly, all blasts converging on a single point ahead of them, causing the Ha'tak's shield to flare up - and ripple, forming a… hole?

“That's not how it works!” Sam blurted out moments before Darla punched through the hole, followed by a Death Glider - with two

more smashing against the shield to either side of the opening and blowing up.

“Someone tell Darla that. On second thought, better don't tell her!” Catra said, baring her teeth as Darla twisted, flying alongside the Ha'tak for a moment, evading a volley from the Death Glider behind them.

“Shoot it down!”

Sam's stomach rose as Darla flipped around, cannon fire from the Ha'tak missing her as the Death Glider rolled in an attempt to evade her volley.

But one shot clipped a wing of the craft, and it spun out of control, detonating against the Ha'tak's side.

“Now let's go in!” She-Ra snarled.

Darla turned again - and Sam gasped when the ship flew straight at the Ha'tak's hull, accelerating as much as possible.

*****

Catra hissed under her breath and held on to Adora when the ship suddenly turned from flying along the Ha'tak's hull to diving at it. This was wrong - Darla didn't feel, didn't fly like that. “Shit!” she cursed, a moment before they crashed into - through - the hull, bracing for a shock that never came.

Instead of being thrown off her feet and across the bridge, she barely felt the ship coming to a stop after having torn up two decks of the enemy vessel.

“Wow! Your inertial compensators are much better than ours! We have to check them out!” Entrapta's voice cut through the sudden silence.

“Later!” Adora snapped. “We have to take out Apophis!”

“I'll cut him down,” her copy yelled, rushing towards the door.

Catra heard Adora mutter a curse under her breath as her lover sped after the other. No choice now - she ran after them as well, dropping on all fours to keep up. The two idiots were racing each other, jumping down the ramp before it had reached the bottom and barrelling through the squad of Jaffa gathered there.

Adora rammed her shoulder into the first on the left, smashing him into the next one, both ending up crashing against the wall with enough force to bend and shatter their armour. The copy cut the other two apart with a single swing of her sword, cutting through armour and flesh. Neither the copy nor Adora slowed down.

Catra jumped over the spreading pools of blood and dug her claws into the floor to keep from losing her footing, cursing some more. “Don't just run off!” she yelled as she rounded the next corner and spotted Adora and the copy ahead of her.

“We can't let him get away!” Adora yelled back. “We need to keep the pressure on!”

“Do you even know where you're going?” Catra was slowly catching up to the two She-Ras, jumping over the remains of another squad of Jaffa splattered against the walls - it looked like neither She-Ra had bothered to use their blades here.

“Not the lift!” Catra spat as she finally reached them. “That's a trap!” Or would become one.

“The shaft will take us up to the bridge!” the copy spat, then jammed her sword through the gap and twisted, forcing the door open.

Catra blinked. “You want to climb up?” A lift shaft? That was a killing zone!

The other She-Ra didn't answer as she stepped inside and looked up, then down before grabbing the ladder set into the wall.

Obviously, this idiot was doing this.

And, Catra realised, her idiot was eyeing the shaft as well. “No!” she snapped. “Let's take the stairs!”

“But… I can climb as well as she can!”

“And I can climb better than either of you, and it would still be stupid! Let's go!” Catra didn't even try to pull Adora with her but whirled and ran towards the stairs, hoping they would be in the same place as in other Ha'taks. The former slaves thinking this up had been on Ha'taks before, hadn't they?

“Catra!” Adora ran after her. As planned.

Catra sliced the door into pieces with her claws, then had to jump to the side as two blasts tore through the opening. Ambush!

But Adora was already moving. She caught the next blast on her sword-turned-shield as she charged past Catra. Grunts and the sound of crushed metal followed.

When Catra rounded the corner and entered the staircase, two Jaffa were dead, one half-embedded in the wall, the other on the ground with his head smashed in, and Adora was already speeding up the stairs.

“Come on! We can't let the other beat us!”

“It's not a competition!” Catra yelled back, jumping up the first flight of stairs, then at the wall, and up the next.

“Tell that to her!”

Catra couldn't help but hope that if there had been another Catra here, she would have handled it better. But it would have been Angella's creation…

They ran past two floors, then a third, as Catra's ears picked up the sound of running Jaffa. “Stop!” she yelled. “Behind us!” She

whirled and jumped back to the last door, claws out, just as it opened.

As the first Jaffa charged through, she grabbed his staff weapon's shaft and pulled, jerking him forward. Her free hand slashed through his neck guard, and he fell down, blood pouring down his back. The next one swung his staff at her, but Catra ducked and sliced through his armoured lower legs, cutting muscles and bones.

The Jaffa screamed and went down as well - but still tried to grab her. Catra twisted out of the way and smashed her foot into his helmet, then dug her claws into it and swept him past her.

That left…

"Duck!"

She dropped down to the ground at once, and a piece of cut metal as large as her torso flew over her head and into the two Jaffa left with enough force to cave in their chest plates. And their chests.

"Come on!"

And Adora was already rushing up the stairs again. She really wanted to beat her counterpart.

Well, at least that would show Angella that you couldn't beat the originals, Catra consoled herself as she followed her idiot.

*****

"Didn't I say you never split the party?" Jack O'Neill complained as he rounded the corner, his M4 ready, but only saw another massacred squad of Jaffa and no sign of either Adora or Catra. The three had vanished in the Ha'tak's interior. Of course, he only had to follow the trail of dead Jaffa to find them…

"She-Ra can handle Apophis - or anyone else!" Glimmer said.

No, not Glimmer. Her copy. ‘Local counterpart’, Daniel would say, but Jack knew they were just a copy. And a bad one, at that. Not only was she panting and obviously not used to running after She-Ras, but she also was far too optimistic for an officer in a war.

“We don't know that - we don't know how powerful Apophis is,” the real Glimmer said. “He's supposed to be a god - and his ship was more powerful than a regular Ha'tak.”

“But so was ours,” Entrapta pointed out.

“Nothing and no one can stand up to She-Ra,” Angella stated. The queen didn't look out of breath. Or as if she had run at all. “She is Etheria's protector.”

“Well, not even She-Ra is unbeatable,” Glimmer retorted. “As we know.”

“Oh! It's like the unmovable object meeting the irresistible force!” Entrapta looked around. “We might find out if multiple minds working together for a short time are more effective in shaping this dimension than one mind with a lot of time to work!”

“What do you mean?” Glimmer's copy asked with a frown.

“Nothing,” Angella said with a glare aimed at Glimmer. “We need to focus on the task at hand - which is defeating Apophis.”

“I thought She-Ra would take care of that,” Glimmer spat back with a scowl. “Suddenly, she's not good enough?”

“Glimmer…” Angella’s scowl deepened.

Jack cleared his throat. Maybe they should have left all the copies back in Darla, not just Entrapta's and Bow's. They were already too bunched up here for his taste. At least Daniel and Sha're had stayed back as well, and… He cocked his head as he heard boots pounding the floor. “Incoming!”

Teal'c was already moving past him, staff weapon out, and fired a moment before the first Jaffa guard squad rushed around the corner. The blast took the leader in the chest and threw him back, toppling two more.

Jack shot the last one standing, placing a burst in his chest and throat, then double-tapped the two remaining before they could get up. “It looks like the first shock and confusion has worn off, and they are rallying - and moving to cut us off,” he said.

“We need to follow She-Ra,” Glimmer's copy said at once. “She's going to Apophis.”

“We need to stop the bombardment and secure the ship,” Jack retorted. “That means taking control of the reactor and engines.” And ensure that Apophis couldn't blow up the ship with them on board.

“This path leads to engineering,” Carter said with a nod. “If the layout at least roughly conforms to standard Ha-taks,” she added with a small frown.

“Well, the reactor and engines are where they should be! Our sensors show that.” Entrapta smiled. “Though they are much more powerful than the ones we know.”

More good news. Jack suppressed a sigh. “Then let's go. Apophis dying won't serve anyone on the ground if Bright Moon gets destroyed.”

Angella nodded after a moment, then turned to Glimmer's copy with a smile. “We have to trust She-Ra to deal with Apophis.”

“Yes, mom!”

Jack glanced at Glimmer and saw that she was clenching her teeth and balling her hands into fists.

He turned away, covering the hallway ahead, and repeated himself: “Let's go!”

Teal'c took point, and they followed the route Carter had chosen. Halfway to the stairs leading down, they had to deal with another squad of Jaffa charging at them. Bow covered all of them in glue with one arrow, and Teal’c Jack and Carter shot the Jaffa before they could wrench their weapons free of the sticky mass.

“That was too easy,” Jack muttered as they reached the stairs. “They just rushed us blindly. Apophis's guards should be better than that.”

“We've fought many of them who did that,” Glimmer objected, peering downstairs while Jack checked upstairs.

“But not quite that rashly. They didn't even try to use cover or ambush us.” And their aim sucked. For Apophis's best, they were rather bad.

“I would never have accepted this performance when I was Apophis’s Prime,” Teal'c agreed.

“The faithful might not have the knowledge to create guards who can use more sophisticated tactics, sir,” Carter suggested.

“Let’s hope that's true,” Jack said. It would be great if things were going their way for once.

They climbed down the stairs without further resistance, and the squad guarding the exit on the reactor level was dealt with with another glue arrow and a grenade. Jack didn't bat an eye at the mess that left, but he saw Bow and Glimmer wince. Not Angella or Glimmer's copy, though.

That said something about this world. Something Jack didn't want to think about right now.

They moved on towards the reactor room. Once they were in control of it, they could cut power to the guns. And to a number of other systems the snakes would rather see working.

*****

She wouldn't let that… that *other* She-Ra beat her. Not to Apophis, not in anything. Adora clenched her teeth as she raced up the stairs - towards the Ha'tak's bridge. Not because she had anything to prove. But she was more experienced than the other Adora, and this was too important. They had to defeat Apophis before he destroyed Bright Moon and took over this dimension. And Adora couldn't trust the other She-Ra with this - the woman was far too…

"Watch out!" Catra yelled from behind. "Incoming!"

Adora changed her sword into a shield and immediately moved it to cover the door ahead of her - Catra's ears were much better than hers. A moment later, the door blew open, pieces bouncing off her shield, and four Jaffa charged through the thin smoke.

Adora swung her shield and smashed all of them into the wall, not bothering to stop before she took the next flight of stairs. A scream cut short, ending in a coughing noise, told her that Catra had taken care of any survivors.

The Jaffa guards here never seemed to learn. They just charged at her, weapons firing, squad after squad. Without flinching, without faltering. Without any thought. Like… bots. Dumb bots.

She pressed her lips together as she reached the next floor. They - and Apophis - had been created by the former slaves of his stranded in this dimension. Was this how they saw the Jaffa? Real Jaffa would adapt, at least somewhat. Even Apophis's most loyal guards would change tactics instead of charging to their doom. And at least some of them would flinch at some point or even retreat. Or surrender and call her a goddess, an unwelcome voice sounding like Priest added in the back of her mind.

Not these Jaffa, though. They showed no emotion. No thoughts.

"This is the deck where the bridge should be," Catra announced.

Adora nodded and stopped in front of the doors, glancing back.

Her love caught up, panting slightly. Her ears twitched. “I don’t hear any guards on the other side.”

That didn't mean there were no guards - Jaffa could stay silent and wait to ambush them. But these guards?

Adora nodded and stabbed her sword through the door, then moved it in a half-circle, cutting an opening wide enough for both of them into it. A swift kick sent it inside, and Adora followed, blade first, with Catra a step behind her and to the side.

The hallway was empty. “Unguarded?” Adora asked.

Catra cocked her head, then dashed forward to the closest corner.

“Catra!” Adora ran after her - why did Catra have to be so impulsive? - but Catra had already stopped. “We're too late,” she said.

Adora reached the corner as well and saw what she meant - the hallway there was filled with dead Jaffa, cut to pieces. And the doors to the bridge had been torn open.

Catra leapt over the pools of blood on the floor, touching down on a clear spot, then jumped up and bounced off the walls twice before landing in the doorway to the bridge.

Adora clenched her teeth and ran, jumping over the last half of the hallway.

The bridge crew had been killed as well, half the screens and consoles smashed. But the other half showed that the Ha'tak was still firing at Bright Moon - and the shield was flickering even more under each impact.

Catra dashed to one of the intact consoles and started pushing buttons before shaking her head. “I can't stop the bombardment. Or redirect it.” She moved to the next console. “And I can't move the ship either.”

“The other She-Ra must have smashed the steering and controls,” Adora said.

“Or these things never really worked as they should,” Catra said, looking up at the ceiling.

Adora frowned. “A decoy?” Apophis was paranoid, as most Goa'uld, so she wouldn't put it past him to build a fake bridge as a decoy to fend off coups and boarding attempts.

“Or the ship directly answers to Apophis.” Catra shrugged. “It's not as if the ship is any more real than anything else in this dimension.”

It felt pretty real to Adora. But she knew what her lover meant: This was a figment of someone's imagination. “Now…”

Catra interrupted her, looking at the ceiling again. “The throne room!”

There was a throne room on this ship? Adora bit her lower lip. Stupid! Of course, there was a throne room on Apophis's ship! “The other She-Ra!” she gasped. She had beaten Adora to the bridge, but Adora wouldn't let her beat her to the throne room! “Let's go!”

They ran out of the room and then to the right as Catra informed the others over the communicator of the bridge status. Ahead of them was a hole through which Adora could see a scorched lift shaft. The other She-Ra must have come through here!

Catra peered inside and sniffed the air, wrinkling her nose. “Up!”

“So, *now* we climb?” Adora asked, already gripping the ladder.

“Obviously, the Jaffa here aren't as skilled as the ones back home if your copy made it through in one piece. Now climb!” Catra retorted in that slightly annoyed tone of hers she used when she was proven wrong.

She was always a little prickly. Adora smiled and kept climbing.

At the top of the shaft was another hole. They must be on the highest deck of the ship. Not the safest location for a throne room - but would the former slaves have known that?

Adora grabbed the ragged edge of the hole and pulled herself through, her sword appearing in her hand. She was in a huge entrance hall, facing a massive gate seemingly made of solid gold. It was closed, and there were no dead guards on the floor - had they beaten the other She-Ra here? But the hole…

Catra appeared next to her, and Adora turned to ask her: "Do you hear anything?"

Catra cocked her head, ears twitching. Then her eyes widened, and she turned to stare at the gate.

Adora grabbed her and jumped to the side.

Just as she landed with the protesting Catra in her arms, the gates were smashed open from the inside, and a white blur crashed into the wall, creating a crater.

A person-shaped crater, Adora realised, with the other She-Ra embedded in it. She slid to the floor, coughing up blood, and stared at the gates with bared teeth.

And from the throne room, a booming voice rang out.

"FOR DARING TO ATTACK YOUR GOD, YOU WILL SUFFER UNTIL YOU BEG FOR DEATH!"

"Looks like this Apophis is tougher than the original," Adora heard Catra mutter another curse under her breath.

She nodded in agreement.

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The Lost Dimension Part 5

Unknown Location, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“We're at the reactor room. Going in,” Samantha Carter heard the General's voice through her communicator as she studied the lock on said door.

“We're at the throne room. Engaged with Apophis.” Catra's voice sounded far tenser than Sam had expected.

She also heard some crushing and grunting noises, followed by some booming boasting and mocking laughter. Things apparently weren't going well for the other group.

“They'll be fine!” Entrapta said. She sounded honest, but Sam had her doubts. The real Apophis would not last long against one, much less two She-Ra's. That meant they had to adjust their estimates of this Apophis's power upwards. Far upwards.

“What's the holdup, Major?” the General asked.

“The lock is more difficult to crack than expected, sir,” she replied with a frown. None of the usual approaches were working - she hadn't even found the lock’s power supply yet. She would have assumed that it was entirely mechanical if not for the fact that she hadn't found any couplings or other ways to move a bar. It was like the lock was… “...a magic lock,” she whispered, her eyes widening.

“Oh! That would explain the data we got!” Entrapta beamed. “How interesting!”

“Magitech?” the General asked.

“No, sir. Magic. I doubt there is any technology in this lock,” Sam corrected him.

“Well, technically, magic is still technology,” Entrapta said. “Although magic in this dimension might not fit the scientific definition, seeing as the laws of nature are so flexible here. On the other hand, we simply might not yet have discovered the underlying physics of this dimension.”

“Magic or magictech - can you crack it?” The General sounded impatient. He would be tense with half their group fighting a battle that sounded more and more desperate the longer Sam heard it play out over the comm.

“Not unless you mean it literally,” Entrapta replied, saving Sam from having to admit her failure. “Glimmer? Can you use your magic?”

Glimmer took a look at the lock and shook her head. “I am not as good a sorceress as Dad. Or my Aunt. And this is a completely different dimension, with magic made up by people who have no idea how it should work. I can't control such an enchantment.”

“Then I guess we need the universal door opener mark IV,” the General said.

“Oh?” Entrapta blinked. Then she saw him pull out a pack of C4. “Oh! That's what you meant!”

Sam was already moving back - the General was an expert on demolitions, but she expected him to err on the side of more blasting power in this situation. “Take cover!” she said, then snagged a tendril of Entrapta's hair to gently pull her friend with her.

Glimmer and the others were already behind the closest corner. Sam had barely hunkered down - keeping a hand on Entrapta to prevent her friend from moving out of cover to take a look - when the General dashed around the corner and crouched down. “Cover your ears!” he said, raising a detonator.

Sam quickly slapped her hands over her ears and opened her mouth. A second passed. Then another.

“Entrapta!”

“Sorry!”

Then, a loud explosion made her ears ring for a moment, followed by a shockwave that, even blunted by the distance and the hallway’s corner, felt like a blow to her chest.

The General was already moving forward, straight into the cloud of dust and smoke that filled the area ahead of them, and Sam caught a glance of Teal'c's form even further ahead before the smoke hid both men from view.

She pulled her goggles down over her eyes and ran after them. The cloud was already thinning when she reached it, but she still almost ran into the remains of the door after half a dozen steps.

Stumbling and cursing herself for it, she made it past the bent and twisted metal into the reactor room - and stopped at once, blinking.

“That's… not a Goa'uld reactor,” she said. Nor was it an Ancient model. Or a Horde core.

“Looks very snakey to me. All that gold and hieroglyphs,” the General commented. with a wave. “Just their style. Too much bling even for the worst gangsta rapper.”

“Yes, sir. But that's purely aesthetics. The whole design doesn't conform to standard Goa’uld reactor technology,” Sam said, taking a few steps closer. And that was a mature technology. This was… something else. Impressive, certainly, and it fit the aesthetics perfectly, though…

Her eyes widened. “Where are the powerlines?” she muttered. The huge, vaguely cylindrical construction was a monstrosity of gold and inlays, and she could see sparks and lightning flash through small gaps in the ornaments, but she couldn't see any lines connected to the thing.

“Oh! The power generated is immense! That's better than our own designs!” Entrapta gushed. “But what's the source? It can't be an antimatter plant, there's no fluctuation - the power is far too steady for that, and yet where is it coming from? It has to be…”

Sam pressed her lips together. Outdone by the Goa'uld? Worse, by an imaginary Goa'uld, thought up by his faithful to… She gasped again.

“Magic!” she breathed together with Entrapta.

“Magic?” the General repeated.

“It's a magic reactor - it runs on magic,” she explained. Or divinity, maybe.

Well, what else should she have expected if a group of people deliberately kept ignorant of technology of any kind were imagining a spaceship for their god? They had no idea how things should work in their universe and assumed it was magic controlled by their god’s whim. The whole ship was just a facade. An illusion. Unburdened by knowledge, science and the limits and demands of known technology.

“The whole ship must be running on make-believe,” she said.

And in a dimension shaped by one’s belief…

She winced. This Apophis was an even greater threat than she had imagined.

As if someone had read her mind, another scream cut through the communicator.

“ADORA!”

*****

“ADORA!” Catra screamed and rushed towards her love.

“I’m OK!”

Adora was lying, Catra knew - her love was struggling to get up from the ground after she had left a hole in the throne room’s wall and a crater in the Ha'tak’s hull.

Catra dropped on all fours and dug her claws into the steel to stop before she rammed into Adora. “Don’t…”

“TREMBLE BEFORE YOUR GOD!” Apophis appeared in the hole in the wall, floating a foot above the ground, power crackling around his hands. “I WILL…”

“FOR THE GLORY OF GRAYSKULL!”

So, the other She-Ra wasn’t dead yet. Catra helped Adora up while her lover’s braindead copy charged at Apophis from the side.

Apophis snarled and turned to face her, hands raised, and a gleaming force field appeared in front of him a moment before the local idiot crashed into it.

“We need to attack together!” Adora blurted out, but before she could get moving, the other She-Ra was sent flying by a burst of power from Aphophis and crashed into the wall on the other side. Like the last half a dozen times she had attacked him.

“She isn’t listening,” Catra spat and tried to drag Adora to the side, out of Apophis’s field of view. “We need to find another way to beat him ourselves.” At least the idiot didn’t seem to stay down no matter how often she was hit by Apophis.

Unlike Adora, Catra added silently. Her love was battered and bruised from that single blow.

“But… Watch out!”

Before Catra could react, Adora pulled her to the side and raised her sword, turning it into a shield to catch a bolt of lightning

Apophis sent at them. The energy crackled as it hit the shield, and Catra felt her fur starting to rise, but Adora stood her ground, baring her teeth at the snake.

“YOU DARE TO DEFY ME?”

“Took you that long to notice?” Catra muttered, quickly glancing around. If the copy managed to distract Apophis again, and Adora could handle another few attacks, Catra might be able to use the wall and one of the holes to get at the snake’s back.

“You’ll never win!” Adora spat, taking a step toward Apophis, shield held high.

Another lightning bolt flew towards her, and the shield stopped it again. Adora wasn’t even pushed back, Catra noted. And yet the same attack had thrown her through a wall just a moment before…

“FOR THE GLORY OF GRAYSKULL!”

Apophis didn’t even bother to turn around - he simply flicked his wrist, and the copy was sent flying again.

“If we keep this up, we’ll wreck the Ha'tak,” Catra whispered. She moved a few steps to the side, closer to the wall. Almost there… She caught Apophis’s eyes turning towards her and dived to the side.

The floor where she had been standing exploded before she hit the ground, lightning sending shards of metal flying. Catra ducked her head and covered it with her arms as they hit her. Most were stopped by her uniform, but one left a cut on her arm, and she hissed with pain when another pierced her tail.

“Catra!” And Adora the idiot rushed towards her, changing her shield into a sword to send a bolt of magic at Apophis that fizzled on his shield.

Apophis didn’t waste the opportunity and hurled another lightning bolt at Adora. It caught her right before she reached Catra, sending her flying again - into the wall next to the lift shaft.

Catra gasped and scrambled up. Adora was… Apophis was… she jumped, dodging another attack, and twisted in the air so she landed on all fours on the rubble left behind by one of the lightning bolts. Her claws dug into the metal and propelled her forward moments before the next attack struck, and a quick dash avoided another, but she couldn’t keep this up forever.

“RAHHH!”

She didn’t have to - the idiot copy’s next attack was as ineffective as the ones before, but while Apophis was blasting her into the other wall, Adora had managed to get up and back into the fight.

“I’m your enemy!” she yelled, advancing toward the snake. “Fight me!”

“YOU ARE A BUG I SHALL CRUSH!” Apophis spat back, followed by two more lightning bolts.

Again, Adora wasn’t moved by the blows she caught on her shield. She wasn’t even slowed down - she kept advancing even though her legs must be hurting.

Catra was missing something. This made no sense. The copy was getting up from blows that should have shattered her, and Adora either shrugged off the attacks or was sent flying by them. The shield alone couldn’t be the reason…

“INSOLENT VERMIN! DIE!”

Apophis unleashed a veritable lightning storm - and Adora stood her ground even as electricity crackled around her body and made her hair stand up - and Catra’s nose smelled an overpowering ozone stench.

The shield couldn’t do this… Catra’s eyes widened. This was a different dimension. Different laws of physics. And magic. “Keep the shield up! He can’t hurt you as long as you have it!”

That was it! They couldn’t fight this as they would fight back home - they had to fight it according to this world! A world created by Angella and a bunch of former slaves.

Catra snorted. All they had to do was think like… Her eyes widened when she saw Apophis turn towards her with a deep scowl and lightning crackling around both hands. She had to dodge! Had to run! Had to get aw…

“DIE!”

She screamed when the lightning storm hit her, pain filling her, and she smelt burning hair before everything went dark.

*****

“CATRA!”

Jack O'Neill winced at Adora's scream coming through the radio - communicator. Things were not going well at all. “Adora? Adora?” he asked.

No answer.

“We've lost contact with them, sir,” Carter announced.

That was even worse news. “We need to get up there,” he said, turning to look at Carter. “Can you do anything with the reactor here?”

She pressed her lips together, a scowl appearing on her face for a moment - annoyed at herself, no doubt, even if it wasn't her fault at all that they were in some magic spaceship. “No, sir, I…”

The entire ship shook, sending everyone stumbling. “It seems their inertial compensators aren't as good as Darla's,” Entrapta,

caught by her own hair, commented in the sudden silence.

The ship hadn't stopped shaking. It felt like a weaker earthquake - but it wasn't stopping. Jack quickly checked that everyone present was OK - no one seemed hurt, even those who had fallen - and then looked at Carter again.

She had gone pale staring at her tool, and Jack felt his stomach drop. “What's going on?” Was someone else attacking the ship? Or was it sabotage? A malfunction?

“There's a massive discharge of energy at the top of the Ha'tak!” Carter blurted out. “A sustained one!”

“Oh…!” Entrapta cut in, her hair tentacle holding out her own tool to Carter. “Look at this! It's out of sync!”

The ship was still shaking. Jack wasn't a tech, but he knew enough about planes to know that this wasn't a good thing. Magical ship or not, that kind of stress tended to literally shake things apart.

“It's Adora,” Glimmer said in a struck tone, looking at the ceiling. “Apophis must have… hurt Catra. Like Horde Prime did.”

“Oh.” Entrapta sounded scared.

And that scared Jack.

Something cracked behind him - in the huge magical reactor.

That scared him even more.

“Change of plan!” he snapped. “We rig the reactor to blow and return to our ship!”

“But Adora needs our help!” Glimmer said.

“She-Ra will save us all!” the local Glimmer said. She didn't sound worried at all.

Angella, on the other hand, didn't seem nearly as confident. She looked like she wanted to say something but stayed silent, staring at the ceiling.

“Teleport the others back to the ship!” Jack said, looking at both Glimmers as he pulled out packs of C-4 from his pockets. “Hurry!”

Glimmer nodded, but her copy scowled and looked at Angella.

This time, the queen did react. “Do it, dear. There's nothing we can do here.”

And Jack turned to look at the reactor, wondering where to put the explosives. And whether or not the reactor would explode before he finished.

*****

“DIE!”

With her magic forming a blaze around her, Adora barely noticed the lightning bolt fizzling out against her shield. Catra was hurt! Again! Adora cradled her limp body with her free arm, staring at her love. She was breathing, but barely. And her fur was singed - burnt - in many spots. This was Adora's fault. If she had taken out Apophis right away, if she had been stronger, quicker, better…

She shook her head, sending tears flying, and pulled Catra close to her chest. “Not again!” she whispered and willed her power to heal her love.

“YOU CANNOT STAND AGAINST A GOD!”

A hail of lightning bolts hit her shield, but she didn't pay attention. She was watching while Catra healed in moments, fur regrowing, twitching muscles relaxing, chest rising smoothly - Adora could feel Catra's heart beat steadily.

“FOR THE GLORY OF GRAYSKULL!”

“STOP PESTERING ME!”

A white blur flew past her and hit the wall in the back. Adora didn't care. Catra was safe. Unconscious but safe. Alive and healthy.

And Adora would make sure that she stayed that way. She slowly raised her head and stared at Apophis over the edge of her shield.

“DIE! CRUMBLE BEFORE MY MIGHT!”

Another lightning bolt hit her shield. She didn't even feel the impact. Apophis couldn't hurt her as long as she had her shield.

Adora took a step forward.

“DIE!”

And yet another lightning bolt uselessly struck her shield.

Adora took another step forward. And one more. She saw Apophis scowl turn into a snarl, exposing his teeth.

He threw a lightning storm at her. She kept walking. Through it. The energy tore up the ground - and sent her counterpart flying again - but didn't touch her.

“I AM YOUR GOD! DIE!”

His eyes flicked to the side for a moment. Just a hint of fear before she sneered at her.

“You are no god,” she told him, narrowing her eyes.

“I AM YOUR GOD!”

More lightning lashed out.

“You are just a figment. A fantasy.” She shook her head. “You're not real.”

“I AM YOUR GOD! BOW TO MY MIGHT!”

“You're a false god!” She glared at him. Just a bit closer…

He started to float back, and she scoffed. “A real god wouldn't flee!”

He froze for a moment. “I AM NOT FLEEING!”

He flew at her, lightning crackling around both fists, eyes glowing with power, as he lashed out.

“DIE!”

She caught his attack on her shield. This time, she felt the impact, felt the pressure, felt his power trying to push her back, trying to overwhelm her.

But she was She-Ra, Princess of Power. Protector of Etheria. She wouldn't falter. Wouldn't fail. She would save her friends and everyone else.

Clenching her teeth, she pushed back. Her boots left dents on the metal floor.

“YOU WILL FAIL! NO ONE CAN STAND UP TO A GOD!”

“I. Will. Not. Fail!” she spat through clenched teeth. She met his eyes and *pushed*.

His force field broke, and she saw his eyes widen a fraction of a second before her shield smashed into his face and sent him flying back - and to the ground.

He slid over the floor, rolling twice before he was stopped by a piece of the torn gates embedded in the metal, and stared at her as if he couldn't believe what was happening.

“This is impossible! You cannot defeat me! I am a god!”

“You are a fake god!” she repeated herself as she advanced on him.

“NO! I AM…”

“FOR THE GLORY OF GRAYSKULL!”

What? Adora glanced to the side, just in time to see her counterpart charge in again, sword held in both hands. “Wait!”

“DIE!”

Another lightning storm erupted around Apophis, and the other She-Ra charged straight into it, screaming about Grayskull.

Adora hunkered down behind her shield, pressing Catra to her body to protect her as electricity raged around her. This was…

The storm vanished. After a moment, Adora peered over her shield.

The other She-Ra was on the ground, smoke rising from her twitching body. But Apophis was on his back, She-Ra's sword sticking out of his chest - piercing where the symbiont was located, or would have been located back in Adora’s dimension. A pool of blood was spreading beneath him. His mouth was moving, trying to form words, but only blood came out.

His eyes met hers, and before Adora could think of what to say, they glazed over, and he grew still.

*****

The reactor was damaged - malfunctioning. Or should be. The cracking sounds coming from it couldn't be indicating anything good. Or shouldn't. Samantha Carter couldn't tell.

She was really sick of dealing with make-believe technology. She should be able to assist the General in placing the charges so they were most effective, but all her knowledge was useless here - the

reactor didn't work according to any physics, any principle she knew. Not even magic, at least not as far as she could tell. Magic had rules.

Glimmer - the real Glimmer - appeared next to her and yelled: “Hold on!”

Sam barely managed to grab the woman's hand when everything disappeared in a cloud of sparkles, and she reappeared in the middle of Darla's bridge. No, in the middle of the bridge of a ship that looked like Darla but was also just a figment of imagination.

Glimmer, panting, disappeared again to fetch the General.

Sam turned to look at her friends. The only ones missing were the General. And, of course, Adora and Catra.

“The enemy ship is turning on its axis!” the other Bow announced.

Sam gasped and checked her tools. And cursed - the Ha'tak was listing to the side, the angle steadily growing. The engines must be struggling.

Through the bridge windows, she saw debris left from their violent entrance, as well as Jaffa corpses, starting to slide down the hallway in front of the ship. The artificial gravity of the Ha'tak was failing, then.

And yet, the artificial gravity and the inertial compensators in this Darla were working so well, Sam hadn't noticed any change inside.

Glimmer reappeared with the General and bent over, chest heaving from exhaustion.

Sam checked her readings. The listing had increased even more - but it was still manageable. At least in theory. This was a spaceship, not a naval vessel.

“Adora! Catra! Where are you?” Bow spoke into his communicator. “We need to leave!”

Sam didn’t hear any reply. The others must have lost their communicators. Or their lives… No! That was…

“The enemy is still firing on Bright Moon,” the other Bow reported.

“The shield is starting to fall,” the other Entrapta added. “It cannot resist much longer.”

“Trigger the charges!” Angella told the General.

“The others are still missing!” Glimmer protested.

“They're She-Ra,” Angella retorted. “They'll be fine.”

She sounded so confident, Sam couldn’t help worrying that she was delusional. Not that she hadn't doubted the woman's sanity before.

“Adora! Catra! Where are you?” Glimmer all but screamed into her communicator.

“They're still firing.”

“Detonate the charges!”

“We don't know if blowing the reactor will stop the guns!” Sam blurted out.

“But it will do something,” Entrapta said. “Probably.”

Sam looked at the General. He was clenching his teeth - she could tell from the twitching of his jaw muscles - but slowly nodded. Then he raised the detonator. “Get us out of here!”

The other Bow moved his hands over the console, and the ship took off - Sam could only tell from the way her viewing angle of the area outside changed.

“Full speed reverse!”

And they shot out backwards.

“Here we go!” the General snapped.

Sam heard a dim explosion. Then her tool beeped an alert - and a series of explosions went off.

“Secondary explosions! The reactor is going!” Entrapta announced.

“The Ha'tak's starting to fall!”

A screeching noise filled the ship - Bow hadn't been able to compensate for the movement from the Ha'tak and keep them steady, so they were now flying backwards through walls and decks, leaving a trail of debris in their wake that was clearly visible through the bridge windows.

Sam held her breath. It was insane! They should be dead, their ship crushed! Physics didn't work that way! Darla's shields shouldn't be able to hold out!

And yet, they did. Suddenly, they were outside the Ha'tak. Sam caught a glimpse of two Darla-sized holes close to each other in the hull before Bow turned the ship around.

And the Ha'tak was descending while venting smoke from several gaps in its hull and listing to the side.

“Adora! Where are you?” Glimmer sounded desperate.

“Adora! Come in!” Even the other Glimmer sounded concerned.

And Angella had grown tense, Sam noted - staring at the top of the Ha'tak, which was starting to fall now.

“Adora…” Glimmer whispered as the Ha'tak dropped below them.

“Look!” Bow - their Bow - suddenly yelled, pointing ahead.

Sam squinted - and saw a bright light appear a bit below the top of the enemy ship. Was that…?

The light turned into a beam, widening, then vanished, leaving a smoking hole in the hull. Was that movement?

The wind ripped the smoke away, revealing a glowing figure in the hole. Sam used her binocs.

“Adora!” Glimmer yelled.

It was her! And she was carrying Catra and the other She-Ra!

And she was standing on a crashing capital ship.

“Get them!” Angella snapped.

“Glimmer!” Bow blurted out - but both Glimmers had already disappeared, leaving two clouds of sparkles.

And reappeared below, next to Adora. Sam saw them move, reach out - and then the Ha'tak hit the ground and everyone disappeared in smoke and fire.

Sam held her breath. Were they…?

But then the bridge sparkled, and five people appeared. Adora, holding the unconscious forms of Catra, with Glimmer. And the other Glimmer with their She-Ra, also unconscious.

“I did…” Glimmer collapsed.

Adora caught her before she hit the ground.

“Glimmer!” Bow rushed to her side.

“Adora!” The other Glimmer was holding on to their She-Ra.

And in front of them, a mushroom cloud of smoke and fire rose from the Ha'tak's crash site.

*****

When Catra came to, the first thing she saw was Adora's face. Although from an angle - she was in Adora's arms. Bridal-style. And Adora wasn't looking at her but at someone else.

"...and we should… Catra's awake!"

That was Glimmer's voice.

"Catra!" Now, Adora was staring at her. Smiling. And trying to crush her ribcage.

"Hey, Adora… bit tight," Catra told her in a whisper.

"Oh!"

The arms holding her relaxed - slightly. They still held her tightly. She smiled at Adora, then noticed that her love had tears in her eyes and reached up to brush them away.

Someone made gagging noises next to them, and Catra scowled. Who was… Ah. Glimmer's copy. Catra should have known. They were on Darla's bridge, she realised a little belatedly, with the others.

Acting as if she hadn't noticed Glimmer's copy, she moved her hand from Adora's cheek to her neck and pulled her love in for a kiss.

"I can't believe it!" Glimmer's copy complained.

"That's… how can you do that?" That was Adora's copy. She sounded shocked. "That's Catra!"

Catra sensed Adora tensing up - probably about to tell the others off - and squeezed her neck slightly, preventing her from breaking off the kiss.

"Gah!"

She smirked when she finally drew back and saw the outraged expressions on the copies' faces - and the mix of embarrassment and amusement on her friends' before she looked at Adora again. "So, you got the snake?"

"Yes."

"I killed Apophis!" Adora's copy cut in.

"After I already defeated him," Adora retorted. She narrowed her eyes at the other. "He always beat you away before I struck him."

Adora's copy scowled at her. "You didn't even use your sword!"

"Exactly!"

"Ah… the main thing is that Apophis is dead, right?" Bow asked with a weak smile. "And his ship is destroyed."

"Yep." Jack nodded.

"And Bright Moon is safe." That was Bow's copy.

So, the smoke in front of the ship was not the kingdom burning but the Ha'tak. That was good news - not that Catra had doubted that Adora would defeat Apophis. But it also meant that Angella didn't have to worry about the snake any more. And that probably wasn't good news.

Catra sighed and wriggled out of Adora's arms. "So, what happened to the former slaves who created Apophis?"

"We don't know their status," Jack said. "If they were on the ship…" He shrugged.

Catra took a closer look at the screens showing the crashed Ha'tak in more detail. The ship had been ripped apart, either from the crash or internal explosions. Several larger parts remained somewhat intact, but between the impact and the fire, anyone who had been inside them was probably dead anyway.

“I've sent troops to their former camp. And we'll search the wreck as soon as it's safe. We have to be sure that they are dead,” Angella said.

“What?” Adora turned to gape at the queen. “They're victims brainwashed by Apophis! If they're alive, they need our help!”

“They created this!” Angella snapped, gesturing at the burning wreck before them. “They are responsible for the destruction of Plumeria, and it's only thanks to She-Ra that Bright Moon still stands! They are too dangerous to be left alive!”

Thanks to She-Ra indeed, Catra thought as she saw the copy nod. My Adora.

“We can't let them summon their god again!” Glimmer's copy said with a scowl that matched Angella's.

‘Summon their god again’? That was an odd way to word it. Did she think that this Aophis had been the real one, summoned and now returned to his home dimension? Was she aware that they were in a dimension where you created everything, even gods, with your imagination? Was she aware that she was such a creation?

Catra narrowed her eyes as she looked at the copies.

“You can't kill them! This wasn't their fault - they were sent here against their will! Once we take them home, they won't be able to create their god any more!” Adora said.

“They are a danger! And traitors - we took them in, helped them, gave them a home, and they tried to destroy us all!” Glimmer's copy protested.

“It's not their fault - they were raised from birth to worship Apophis!” Glimmer cut in. “You can't expect them to change without telling them the truth about the Goa’uld!”

“The first thing their god did when he appeared was to attack us and destroy Plumeria. Since he was their creation, they would have known that would happen,” Angella said - with a frown aimed at Glimmer.

The copies nodded again. Did they know they were created as Apophis was? Or did they think they were real? Could they influence this world as the former slaves and Angella - and Catra's friends - could? If so, did they know that? Or were they just ignoring everything that would make them question themselves?

Catra couldn't tell. But she was sure they had to find out. This was the key to sorting out this whole mess. If the copies were just figments, the only people who mattered - the only real people - in this dimension were Angella and the former slaves, if they were still alive. But if the copies were people…

That would be an even bigger mess. Especially if they depended on Angella’s imagination to exist.

*****

Jack O’Neill really wanted to leave this dimension. Ideally before someone else summoned another crazy god. Or something worse. Or the weirdness started to affect himself.

And he very much wanted to leave before they started a fight with the locals. That was never a good idea, no matter whether you were on a black ops mission in another country or on a rescue mission in another dimension.

Doubly so if the fight was about saving a bunch of people who had tried to kill you and your friends pretty damn hard for quite some time. Jack couldn’t really fault the queen for her attitude - if those former slaves had summoned Aphopis and his magical Ha’tak to Earth and might try again, he would want to put a few rounds into each of them himself - brainwashed former slaves or not.

Of course, other opinions differed.

“They were raised to obey their god blindly!” Glimmer protested. “Of course, they would pray to him. That this dimension reacted to their prayers and created Apophis wasn’t their fault!”

“This dimension gave them exactly what they asked for. They are responsible for the destruction caused by their god!” The queen glared at Glimmer.

In fact, the two queens were facing each other rather closely. Not very queenly at all. It looked more like a family spat than a diplomatic disagreement.

“They were raised like this from birth! Indoctrinated! Under pain of death! Did you expect them to abandon their religion?” Glimmer spat. “Just like that? That’s not how it works!”

“It is true that many of the False Gods’ slaves, both human and Jaffa, blindly follow what they were taught from birth,” Teal’c spoke up. “However, their minds are not held in thrall. Only their own choices prevent them from questioning their false gods dogma.”

Jack nodded. Like Teal’c had done. And Bra’tac.

“That’s not entirely fair,” Daniel spoke up. “It takes a lot of strength to abandon the society you were a part of since birth. Even more so if it involves cutting ties with your family and friends. And, of course, risking death by doing so - or, if you are religious, your very soul.”

“They were not at risk here!” Angella retorted. “They were safe from their god. They chose to bring their evil god here!”

“That’s because that was all they knew!” Glimmer put her hands on her hips. “Did you even talk with them? Explain that their god was fake and evil? Try to help them change?”

“Why would I? I had no idea that their god was like this!” Angella scoffed. “They told us that the goddess Taweret sent them here to die but that their god would save them.”

“Well, it doesn’t look like that worked out for them,” Jack commented, glancing at the smoking remains of the crashed Ha’tak.

“We don’t know that they were on board! They could have stayed at their camp!” Glimmer snapped.

“Then they are likely dead - killed by the guns of their own god.” Angella sniffed. “In either case, they must face the consequences of their actions.”

“They need help! We need to deprogram them! Show them that their god was a lie!” Adora shook her head. “Like the Horde - either Horde - they didn’t know any better!”

Catra coughed. “Most of us in the Horde knew that what we were doing was wrong,” she said in a low voice. “You were kind of the exception.”

That earned her a glare from Adora. “We were taken in as babies and raised as soldiers!”

“And you defected as soon as you had the opportunity,” Catra told her.

“Because I met Glimmer and Bow and found the Sword of Protection.” Adora shook her head.

“And because, well, you’re Adora,” Glimmer added. “We can’t expect everyone to be like you.”

“When we had the opportunity, after meeting you, we rebelled against Ra,” Sha’re said, looking at Daniel.

“Well, yes, but those were special circumstances. Would you have rebelled without our arrival?” Daniel smiled. “Those people never had that chance.”

“We welcomed them,” Angella said. “We cared for them. We provided them with food, shelter and any help they needed to

start a new life. And yet, they chose to summon their evil god and attack us."

"Can't argue that," Jack said.

"That doesn't mean they cannot change!" Adora retorted. "We need to talk to them, explain things, and give them a chance!"

"We need to find out if they are still alive first," Catra said. "If they are all dead…" She shrugged. "No point arguing in that case."

"Yes!" Adora nodded firmly. "Let's check the crash site. And their former camp. And no killing them!" she added with a frown at Angella.

"We cannot risk them repeating their deed," Angella protested. "I cannot put Etheria at risk."

She had a point there as well. But Jack knew Adora. She wouldn't agree. "Then let's hurry," he said. "We shouldn't waste time." They had already wasted enough time.

Jack wanted to leave this dimension yesterday.

*****

This was all wrong! You shouldn't kill people just for being a threat - and without even talking to them! Adora couldn't believe this Angella wanted this - it went against everything the Alliance stood for. Either Alliance. Adora shook her head as Darla closed in on the burning wreckage of the Ha'tak.

At least the queen had agreed to order her soldiers to check for surviving former slaves and capture them instead of having them killed. That was something. For a moment, it had looked as if they would come to blows - or worse - over that. Glimmer had been spitting mad - Adora's friend was still fuming, actually, and keeping her distance from this Angella as much as possible without leaving the bridge.

And this Angella was ignoring her. And everyone else, it seemed - even her Glimmer and Adora. Angella was just staring at the wreck or at the soldiers surrounding it.

"Oh! Mermista is here - look at the fire she just put out!" Entrapta piped up. "She must have transported the water all the way from the lake!"

"Or created it on the spot," Catra muttered next to Adora.

Adora frowned at the reminder that this wasn't an alternate Etheria. They weren't in a parallel universe but a different dimension with, as Sam had put it, 'completely different laws of nature'. Reality wasn't real here - or only as real as you wanted. And that included the people.

She glanced at the other Adora, who was standing next to Angella. She looked like Adora had, years ago. But she didn't act like Adora would have, now or back then. She was far too… brutal. And… stubborn wasn't the right word. Single-minded? Even at her worst, Adora hadn't been like that. Not at all.

Maybe that was because the other Adora didn't have Catra. This dimension's Catra was dead. Killed by the Alliance. Maybe even by this Adora. Personally.

Adora shuddered at the thought. If she had killed Catra… She didn't want to imagine what that would have done to her. To kill your love… Could there be anything worse you could do?

She wrapped an arm around Catra and pulled her close. Catra made a surprised noise, squirmed a moment, but then settled. Good. Adora wouldn't let go of her. Not ever.

The bridge was silent on the final approach to the wreck. Even Entrapta didn't say anything as she and Sam were fiddling with the sensor they were setting up. That was actually a bit weird, wasn't it? Adora considered checking up on them, but that would have meant releasing Catra.

Then the ship touched down - far smoother than their own Darla would - right in front of the largest piece left of the Ha'tak - the remains of the top. Where they had fought Apophis.

“We'll need to stop the fires before we can search the wreckage,” Angella said. “Mermista is working hard, but that will take some time. I'm not going to risk my soldiers’ lives.”

“You won't have to,” Adora told her. “We can check ourselves - with our scanners.” This Darla might fly much more smoothly than hers, but her friends had the better sensors. As far as they could tell, at least, with how easily things could change here.

She looked at Entrapta and Sam. “Can you detect any survivors?”

“Ah…” Entrapta trailed off and looked at Sam, biting her lips. That was a bad sign.

And Sam looked like she had just been told she would have to eat Horde rations for a week. The brown ones. But she nodded anyway. “We had to recalibrate our scanner. The way we detected dimensionally displaced people before, looking for the changes they cause in the environment, was not a viable way to find them since the entire wreck is such a change.”

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded. “So, we had to find another way to find them. Something that set them apart from this dimension's native people.” Adora felt Catra tense up and hugged her more tightly as Entrapta went on. “We picked constants that differ between parallel universes - we had data about that from Beta’s earlier experiments, before the war with the Horde Prime. So… we found a constant that seems unique to our dimension by cross-checking with the readings from us and what data we had from the Quantum Mirror.”

And she trailed off again.

“Carter?” Jack sounded concerned. He must have picked up as well that something was wrong.

“We only detected one such constant outside our own team in the vicinity, sir,” Sam replied.

“One survivor?” Jack frowned.

Adora frowned as well. If all the others had died, they must have been very lucky to survive.

“In a manner of speaking, sir.” Sam sounded tense. And she was… glancing at Angella?

“Shit!” Catra whispered next to her.

Oh.

Adora blinked. Then she got it. And stared at Angella. She was…?

“NO!” Glimmer yelled. “She can't be my mom! Mom would never do what she has done!”

Oh, no!

*****

The Lost Dimension Part 6

Unknown Location, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Mom would never do what she has done!”

Samantha Carter pressed her lips together as she listened to Glimmer’s outburst. That was exactly what Entrapta and she had feared would happen when they revealed the results of their scans. But trying to hide this would have made things even worse - you didn't try to ‘manage’ your friends like that.

Although, in hindsight, perhaps they should have attempted to inform their friends, especially Glimmer, in a more discreet manner, Sam added when she saw Angella turn to glare at her apparent daughter.

“You claim to be my daughter?”

“No!”

“Um.” Entrapta raised a hand. Both Queen Angella and Glimmer turned to glare at her, and Sam saw her friend flinch. But Entrapta slowly nodded and went on: “It’s not a claim - data doesn't lie. Your dimensional constants match, so you're from the same dimension. Theoretically, one of you could be a clone or impostor, but we check regularly for that in case Double Trouble tries to infiltrate the Alliance, and so we can be sure that this is our Glimmer. And who would have made a clone of Angella and left her in this dimension, way before we even knew about it?”

“Loki,” the General said in a flat voice. “That's the kind of thing he would do.”

Sam couldn't really argue that. Loki wasn't quite as bad as the other Asgard and the General and several others who had met him claimed, but Sam would be lying to herself if she tried to pretend that Loki wouldn't be able to conduct this kind of irresponsible, unethical and semi-random experiment.

But she also knew that the odds that Loki actually had done this, and then kept it secret, were about zero. If he had had the kind of access to Etheria that he would have needed to clone Angella and know enough about her to imprint on the clone, their encounter with him and especially their deal would have gone far differently.

So she nodded in agreement with the General. “In theory, yes. But in my opinion, Loki didn't have the opportunity or motivation to do this.”

The General pouted at her for a moment but didn't contradict her.

“Anyway!” Entrapta said. “If we can safely dismiss Loki as the one responsible - and we absolutely can - who else could have done this?”

“I am not a clone!” Angella snapped.

Entrapta looked at her. “That's what I am saying? Kinda?”

Angella didn't stop frowning, not that Sam had expected her to. But She also hadn't expected the local Glimmer to stay silent - or the local She-Ra. She would have thought they would react to the claim that this Angella wasn't their Angella but a visitor - or impostor - from another dimension.

Unless, of course, they were created by Angella not to question Angella. Consciously or subconsciously. And that was a tangent that Sam wasn't sure she wanted to explore.

“I am not a clone. And you are not my daughter,” Angella said. “Glimmer would never work with the Horde - the same criminals who almost destroyed our entire world if not for my sacrifice!”

Glimmer actually flinched at that. And Sam saw that Catra’s ears were lying flat against her head.

Adora shook her head. “How can you say that? Years have passed since… that day. People changed. We changed.”

“I grew up,” Glimmer said, straightening. “I am Queen of Bright Moon now. Have been for years.” She took a step closer to Angella. “*My* Mom would know that. And *my* Mom would never kill people without giving them the chance to change.”

“Nor would *my* daughter leave threats to our world be!” Angella retorted.

“But this isn't your daughter, is it?” the General cut in, pointing at the local Glimmer, Adora and Bow.

“How dare you say that!” the local Glimmer spat at once. “I won't let you insult us like that!”

“Yes!” the local She-Ra moved forward, sword in hand. “We won't!”

The General took a step back. “Didn't you listen to what Angella just admitted? And implied? That she isn't from this dimension?”

“Liar!” the local Glimmer spat.

“Liar!” the local Adora chimed in.

The local Bow didn't say anything but did draw his weapon.

“Stop!” Adora stepped in front of the three… people? Sam was really starting to doubt that they were sapient individuals. “There's no reason to fight.” She turned to Angella. “Calm them down.”

Angella frowned, her eyes scanning the room, then slowly nodded - although with her lips twisted into a scowl. “Do not start fighting them,” she told them.

The local Glimmer nodded at once and took a step back, lowering the staff she had been holding at the ready. The other two followed her example, and Sam sighed silently with relief.

They had to avoid that at almost any cost. A fight against Angella, in a dimension she had been shaping for years, would be a catastrophe. Sam cleared her throat. “We need to check the camp where the former slaves had been as well. We have to be sure that they aren't hiding somewhere.”

Angella stared at her before slowly nodding, and Sam felt relieved again. Almost as relieved as if she had disarmed a bomb. Which was a rather fitting comparison, she had to admit.

*****

So, this Angella was their Angella. Catra had… not suspected. Feared it? That would fit better. The one who had created this weird, mad version of their home world and had become its queen, the one who had the local Horde wiped to a man - with the exception of Shadow Weaver, for some reason - was the former leader of the Princess Alliance and Glimmer’s mother.

“Figures,” she muttered under her breath as she watched Angella on Darla’s bridge.

“Hm?” Adora turned around and looked at her. “What did you say?”

“Nothing,” Catra replied reflexively. “Just… thinking how weird this is,” she added after a moment.

Adora nodded with a sigh, then glanced at Glimmer, who was standing next to them and glaring at Angella. Though the way her eyes shifted, she was probably glaring at the other Glimmer as well.

Damn, Glimmer must be going through hell right now. She found her mother thought lost forever, only to realise that Angella had gone crazy and had replaced Glimmer with a copy she made up in her mind. A copy with a pretty simple mindset. Or a pretty simple mind - the copies here certainly didn’t act very independently.

In a way, it was a blessing that Angella had killed off the entire Horde here. Created, then killed off, actually, which was messed up in a lot of ways, but that was another topic. But Catra was quite relieved she didn't have to look at a copy of herself made by Angella. It would probably be a blood-thirsty, cruel, and stupid madwoman bent on hurting everyone else - a crazy killer.

She clenched her teeth at the thought. Adora and Glimmer might be disturbed by the caricatures Angella had created in their image, but neither had been like those versions standing next to Angella.

Unlike Catra.

She pushed the thought away. She had changed. She was changing, still. And this wasn't the time to dwell on that, anyway. Not with the current problem they had to deal with. "So…" she trailed off, nodding in Angella's direction, then looked at Adora and Glimmer.

"That's not Mom," Glimmer hissed.

Adora winced. "But Entrapta and Sam checked."

Glimmer scowled.

Ador went on: "And Bow went over their data." At Glimmer's request. And he had confirmed it. Twice.

"I know," Glimmer spat, and Catra put her hand on Adora's shoulder and squeezed gently.

"Ah." Adora winced again.

Catra didn't say anything.

"It's… Mom never acted like that, like… some bloodthirsty bitch!" Glimmer spat.

"Yes," Adora said. "Angella was kind."

“People can change,” Catra said. She didn’t have to add ‘for the worse’ - her friends understood what she meant.

“But not like this!” Glimmer shook her head. “And even if she changed, why would she make everyone in the world like her?” She shook her head. “Is that how she saw me?”

Was she about to cry? Catra pressed her lips together and tried to ignore it.

“I don’t think so,” Adora said. “She didn’t want you to risk your life, but…” she trailed off.

“Really?” Glimmer scoffed through clenched teeth. “Then why is she happy with a daughter who’s all ‘rah, rah, fight’?”

Adora didn’t answer that, so Catra sighed and said. “She must have changed.”

“A lot,” Adora agreed. “She was alone for years. No friends. No one. That’s… not healthy.”

Catra nodded. She knew what having no friends any more felt like.

“Then why didn’t she create a world where everyone is happy? Instead of bloodthirsty?” Glimmer asked. And those were tears on her cheeks.

“They probably were happy before, ah, this happened,” Adora said.

And after they had killed the Horde, Catra added silently. But it was a good point - Catra showing up would have made them fear another Horde attack. And then Apophis actually invaded.

“So, she was happy with *that* Glimmer?” Glimmer spat. “Her obedient daughter?”

Oh. Catra winced. She wasn't touching that. Not even if she could do it in a hovertank.

Adora grimaced as well but bravely tried to console her anyway. "Uh… She was happy with a daughter willing to fight, like you were?"

Glimmer scoffed again. "Then why wasn't she happy with me while she was still with us?"

Catra wasn't touching that either. At least, Glimmer seemed to have accepted that this was her mom. Even if that didn't seem to help their situation.

Or answer the big question in the room: What do we do with Angella?

*****

Jack O'Neill wasn't a coward. He had faced death without flinching before. He had told off Goa'uld who held him prisoner and risked his life many times over doing missions for Stargate Command (and before that, for the US government, but those missions were still classified).

He hadn't volunteered to escort Carter and Entrapta to the former slaves' former settlement because he was afraid of becoming collateral damage to a blow-up between Glimmer and Angella escalating into the use of magical weapons of mass destruction, or whatever this messed-up dimension would create for them. The odds of that happening weren't as low as he would like, but he still wouldn't bet on them. And if anything like it happened, he'd bet on Adora settling matters, She-Ra style.

That he was glad that he hadn't stayed on the ship, where the tension was thick enough to cut with a knife - probably thick enough you needed a really sharp one - was because he didn't like family drama and all the awkwardness it brought up. If anyone doubted it, they could ask his family. There was a reason he hadn't attended any family holiday for the last decade. And

hadn’t bothered to return any calls after Stargate Command had gone public and his position with it.

Also, Jack could claim without lying or bragging that he was a good officer and knew how to lead soldiers, and he might be a bit more skilled at the whole staff rank politics than he would like to be, but family counselling wasn’t one of his strengths. Again, people who doubted him could ask his family. As long as they didn’t pass on any messages from them.

“Alright! We’ve set up the scanner!” Entrapta announced, and Jack focused on the mission.

“Good,” he said, walking past the still-smoking ruins of a nice little cottage-style building to join her and Carter in what used to be the centre of a small village before someone had wrecked it - using rather personal means; there weren’t any craters left by heavy weapons, much less a Ha’Tak’s main guns. No, the buildings had been wrecked with small arms or just set on fire. “The perimeter’s clear.” Neither Jack nor Teal’c had found any enemy - or survivor - hiding nearby. And Daniel hadn’t stumbled on any hidden survivor while looking for clues about the local culture or whatever, and he was usually a decent tripwire for such things. Teal’c had found tracks leaving the village, but he hadn’t been able to tell if they had been laid before the attack or during it.

“Let’s see what the scanner will show, then!” Entrapta sounded as enthusiastic as ever, at least to Jack - her mood had improved significantly since they had left the ship.

“Initiating preliminary scan,” Carter said, pushing a button.

Jack saw a few lights flash on the scanner, followed by a distinct humming noise. Either would make using the scanner while hiding from the enemy a risky proposition, he noted. Then again, this wasn’t a finished model but just what the two - and Bow, who had stayed with Glimmer to keep her company and keep her from

starting a pseudo-civil war in alternate Bright Moon - had thrown together on the fly.

“Multiple traces of extra-dimensional influence detected,” Carter reported.

Well, they already knew that the former slaves and test subjects of Apophis had been settled here.

“Initiating primary scan,” Carter went on.

“That will take a while,” Entrapta said. “We have to check for minor variations and continuing effects before we can check for the different constants. Sorry, but with the processing power available to us, we can’t speed up the code to recognise patterns.”

“That’s OK,” Jack said.

“I’ve tried to create better matrices and crystals by thinking about them, but it didn’t work - we haven’t been here long enough yet to sufficiently influence the dimension,” Entratpa went on.

That… wasn’t OK. Jack forced himself to smile and nodded, then glanced at Carter and raised his eyebrows. She should know better than to attempt to use their imagination to create anything in this crazy dimension. A bunch of former slaves had created their evil god, and Jack was sure that their imagination paled when compared to what Entrapta could think of.

Carter straightened, but her expression was a bit too controlled and bland to be genuine. “We have detected no sign that we’re in danger of accidentally influencing the local dimension in a dangerous manner, sir.”

What Entrapta had mentioned hadn’t been accidental, but before Jack could make a properly sarcastic comment about that, Entrapta piped up again. “Oh! We’ve got a contact! And it’s an active one!”

“A dimensional traveller still actively influencing the environment,” Carter explained.

“I understood that,” Jack commented.

“Sorry, sir.”

“Oh! The secondary scan revealed that it’s not one, but several contacts!” Entrapta cheered.

“Checking for dimensional constants,” Carter said.

Right, best cover all bases. Sure, those ‘travellers’ were almost certainly the missing former slaves, but this was such a weird dimension, Jack would rather check before making assumptions that might end up biting him in the ass.

“Constants confirmed to be identical to ours, sir,” Carter said after about half a minute.

“So, our missing snake-worshippers did survive. At least some of them.” Jack nodded. “Let’s go gather them up before they summon another god-snake.” And before some locals found them and decided to ‘disobey’ Angella’s orders.

“Yes, sir. I’ve sent the coordinates to your tablet.”

“Right. My tablet.” Jack pulled the tablet out of his pocket and opened it in map mode. He would prefer an actual printed map - despite the destructive testing done on them, those gadgets just felt too flimsy, no matter if they were magitech or not - but he couldn’t argue that they were useful when they worked.

A map of the surrounding terrain appeared, with coordinates and symbols blinking, indicating their position and their targets’. The map wasn’t perfect, nor as detailed as Jack would like, just based on their scans, but it was better than nothing.

“Let’s go. We’ll gather Teal’c, Daniel and Sha’re on the way. Provided we can pry Daniel away from the ‘cultural artefacts’ left

behind in the rubble here."

*****

Jack and the others had discovered the missing former slaves and were on the way to recover them. And Adora was standing on the bridge of this Darla and doing… nothing.

She pressed her lips together. She felt so useless! Glimmer was so angry - and hurt - and Adora couldn't do anything to help her. They had found Angella, who had sacrificed herself to save Etheria - and had prevented Adora from sacrificing herself - but she had changed so much, Adora wouldn't have recognised her.

No wonder the world Angella had created was so different. No, so messed up - the Angella Adora had known wouldn't have wanted to kill helpless people who didn't know any better and just followed what they had been taught since they had been children! And she wouldn't have treated her daughter so coldly! Certainly not after having been missing for years!

And the Angella Adora had known wouldn't have replaced Glimmer - and Adora, and everyone else - with some copies who acted so strangely. She had been kind, not cruel. And she had loved her daughter! What had happened to Angella? How could she have changed so much?

"I think it's because she was lost for years in an empty dimension that changes according to your whim," Catra said in a flat tone.

Oh. Adora must have said the last line out loud - or whispered it; Catra was so close, her ears would pick it up anyway. She glanced at her love, about to agree, then noticed Catra's expression and the way her ears laid flat against her head. Oh. "That wasn't your fault."

That earned her a glare. "The hell it wasn't! I opened the gate that she closed."

"But…" Adora pressed her lips together again. Catra isn't wrong, there. But Catra had changed. For the better. And Angella had changed for the worse.

And Adora didn't know why. If Angella could change like this, could anyone else? Could Adora end up like this dimension's Adora?

If someone killed Catra…

She drew a sharp breath through her clenched teeth. If anyone killed Catra, Adora would kill them. Was that why Angella had become like this? Why she had created and then wiped out the Horde in this dimension? Because she had lost her family? Though she had known that Glimmer, Adora and her friends were alive - Angella had sacrificed herself to save them.

Or was Catra right, and Angella had gone mad in her isolation here? Mad enough to recreate a warped version of Etheria? A world changing according to her whims?

Adora's eyes widened. Did she know she had created the world? Wait - Angella obviously knew that; she had said as much when they had been talking about the former slaves. But had she known that when she had created the world?

"I have to ask her," she muttered, glancing at Angella again.

"Ask her what?" Catra cocked her head at her with a frown.

"Why she changed."

"You think she'll tell you?" Catra scoffed.

Adora wanted to say that asking wouldn't hurt, but… It would probably hurt. On the other hand, Glimmer was hurting. She was still standing with Bow in the corner, all tense and ready to bite off anyone's head.

“We need to know why,” Adora said. She wouldn’t be able to help anyone if she didn’t know why things had gone so wrong here. She nodded firmly at her own words.

“Well, I’m sure we can…” Catra started to say, then added: “Wait! You mean right *now*?”

But Adora was already halfway to Glimmer. “Glimmer!”

“What?” Glimmer spun around, glowering at her for a second.

Adora nodded at her. “Come! We’ll find out what happened to your mom!”

“What?” “What?” Glimmer and Bow said together. “Right now?” Glimmer asked, glancing at Angella.

“Shouldn’t we wait until we have recovered the surviving former slaves?” Bow asked.

“Apparently not,” Catra said. Adora didn’t need to look at her to know her expression.

She shook her head. “No more waiting. We’ll find out what happened to your mom.” What changed her.

“Here?” Bow looked pointedly at the other people on the bridge.

Catra shrugged. “It’s not as if they are real people. You saw that. They ignore whatever Angella said if it doesn’t fit them.”

“They don’t ignore us the same way, though,” Bow said.

He wasn’t wrong, but Adora was done with waiting. And they could take their copies, anyway - the other Adora had been useless against Apophis until Adora had broken the fake god’s shield.

“Besides, they’ll probably get upset anyway once we take Angella home,” Catra said.

Adora gasped. That was… She hadn't considered that. But it was obvious, wasn't it? Whatever was the reason for Angella's change, staying here wouldn't help her. And Adora would help here. She owed Angella far too much to abandon her.

"But what if she doesn't want to come home?" Bow asked. "We can't exactly force her to come with us, can we?"

"Of course, we can," Catra replied.

Adora nodded. Catra was right. They would take Angella home no matter what.

Glimmer nodded as well.

Angella turned to face them before they reached her and narrowed her eyes at them. Adora pressed her lips together and kept walking. "We need to talk."

"Leave her alone!" The other Adora moved between her and Angella, followed by the other Glimmer and Bow.

Had she really looked like that, years ago? Adora pushed the stray thought away and focused on Angella. The others don't matter, she told herself. "What happened to you?"

Angella pressed her lips together for a moment, and Adora managed not to flinch. Then the other woman straightened, and her expression smoothed out before it turned into a faint smile. For a moment, she looked exactly like the woman Adora remembered - but her smile was polite, not warm. "You know what happened to me. You were there."

Adora had been there. At the portal. The memories were painful, but she wouldn't ever forget how Angella's last words before she stepped into the portal. "Not that. What happened afterwards?"
What did change you?

"What did change you?" Glimmer asked, echoing Adora's thoughts as she moved to stand next to her - and a little in front.

Angella glared at her. “Change me?”

“Yes!” Glimmer blurted out. “You weren’t like this!”

“Oh, great!” Adora heard Catra mutter on her other side.

“Like what?” Once again, Angella looked like the Angella Adora remembered - when she was arguing with her daughter.

“Like some bloodthirsty maniac!” Glimmer snapped. “The mother who raised me wouldn’t have killed the entire Horde!”

Angella bared her teeth for a moment. “Really? I remember a daughter who always wanted to go and kill the Horde scum!”

Adora winced and glanced at Catra. Her love’s smile had worn very thin, and while she was showing a bland expression, her tail was swishing back and forth, showing how agitated she was.

“I wanted to fight the Horde, yes! But killing them all? We took them prisoner when we could!”

“In a war, you kill your enemies before they kill you!” Angella spat. “I would have thought you’d understand that.”

“No! You *defeat* your enemies!” Glimmer retorted. “And once you’ve won, you make peace!”

“Peace that will be broken as soon as the enemy recovers enough to fight again.” Angella scoffed. “You can’t be safe until your enemy is dead. If you leave them alive, you put your friends and families at risk.”

“That is wrong! You can make peace with your enemies! Turn them into allies and friends!” Adora spoke up. *And more than friends and allies.*

Angella narrowed her eyes at her. “How naive. If you trust your enemies, they will exploit this.”

“I was a Horde soldier myself!” Adora told her. Angella couldn’t have forgotten that, could she?

“*You* never fought us.” Angella scoffed again. “You switched sides as soon as you had the opportunity. You didn’t wait until you were defeated to abandon the Horde.”

Adora glared at her. “Catra risked her life to save Glimmer from Horde Prime! And he was about to defeat us all!”

Angella drew back, eyes widening, but quickly recovered. “A likely story!”

“I was there!” Glimmer cut in. “And you don’t have a leg to stand on - you trusted Shadow Weaver!”

“I did not trust that… woman,” Angella retorted. “I used her knowledge against the Horde. But trust her? Never! Did you think I was such a fool?”

Adora winced when Glimmer drew back. That was a sore point for her friend.

But before she could say anything, Glimmer blurted out: “You trusted her to lead us to the Portal!”

“I did. But if you had killed your enemies when you had the opportunity, the portal wouldn’t have been built in the first place,” Angella replied with a sneer at Catra.

What? Did Angella expect Adora to kill Catra? She stared at the woman. She couldn’t mean that, could she?

“We don’t kill prisoners!” Glimmer spat. “You taught me that!”

Prisoners? Oh. She must be talking about the time Glimmer and Bow had captured Catra!

“So you took that to heart, even though you complained about everything else I did in the war?” Angella snorted but without any

humour. “If you had killed your enemies at the first opportunity - if I had killed them - we would have been safe. Etheria would have been safe. I learned that lesson, but it’s obvious that you never did.”

“Because it’s the wrong lesson!” Glimmer yelled.

“It’s the truth! You cannot trust your enemies! The only way to be safe, to keep your family safe, is to kill them all! If we had done that, I wouldn’t have lost you or Micah!”

“I told you, Micah’s alive,” Catra spat.

“You lie!”

“No! Dad’s alive! We saved him!” Glimmer shook her head. “And he’ll be so disappointed in what you have become!”

Angella froze for a moment, gasping.

As did Glimmer.

And Adora heard Catra hiss a curse.

Angella stared at Glimmer, lips moving for a moment, forming words without sound.

Glimmer grimaced but straightened her shoulders and met her eyes defiantly.

Both stared at each other, and Adora drew a slow breath. She had to say something, anything, to… fix this. Somehow. But before she could think of what to say that wouldn’t make things worse, Angella turned and walked away.

“This isn’t over! You can’t just walk away!” Glimmer yelled. She tried to rush after Angella, but the other Glimmer appeared in front of her.

“Leave Mom alone!”

“She’s not *your* mom!” Glimmer snapped.

“She is my mother!”

“Well… in a sense, Angella created her…?” Bow trailed off with a wince at the glare he received from Glimmer.

“That would make her everyone’s mom!” Glimmer scoffed.

“Congratulations. You just got fifty million siblings,” Catra said.

“Don’t joke about this!” Glimmer snarled, turning to face Catra.

“Why not?”

“It’s not funny!”

The other Glimmer didn’t react to their bickering. Nor did the other Bow. Or anyone else Adora could see. Like everyone else had ignored the entire conversation with Angella. No, Adora corrected herself. They weren’t ignoring them - the others showed absolutely no reaction. It was as if they didn’t hear anything. Or couldn’t hear anything.

This wasn’t the first time Adora had seen this. Had Angella created them like that? Unable to even notice anything that would question her or the world she had made? She looked at her counterpart - or copy - and couldn’t help wondering if the reason this She-Ra was so… so weird was because she couldn’t question Angella.

Like a dumb bot unable to disobey its programming. Like Light Hope, Adora thought, remembering her and how she had been forced to act by her creators. But despite her programming, Light Hope had been a person, hadn’t she?

Were those people here like Light Hope in that way? Were they people?

*****

Even with the map created by the scanner, it took them an hour to reach the area where the surviving former slaves of Apophis were. By the time they crested the last hill on the way, Samantha Carter was feeling a little nostalgic - it had been a while since she had hiked like this on an alien planet with the rest of SG-1.

"They should be straight ahead - well, straight down, in the valley below!" Entrapta announced. Her visor hid her face, but her voice clearly showed her enthusiasm.

"Great!" Daniel sounded happy as well, though part of that was likely because he was relieved that they had reached their goal; he had stuffed his rucksack with all the artefacts he had found in the ruins of the village, and while he hadn't exactly gone out of shape, as the General had joked, Sam had no doubt that he wasn't as used to marching on foot as he had been back in Stargate Command.

Sha're, on the other hand, showed no sign of being winded. Amaunet had kept her host in perfect shape. And she had been possessed for years, so some of the effects of that would linger.

"So, anyone spot our missing god-creators?" the General asked, looking down into the valley. "Smoke from a campfire?"

"I do not think they would risk detection by making a fire," Teal'c commented.

"Let me scan for them again!" Entrapta said. She wasn't exhausted at all since she had used her hair for walking.

Sam nodded and pulled up her tool. This shouldn't take too long.

"Ah, there they are!" the General announced before she could finish her scan.

He was pointing ahead at… a small clearing? Sam raised her own binocs and saw movement there - someone was walking through the underbrush.

“Let’s go and get them before they move again!” The General started down the hillside at a quick pace.

It took them about ten minutes to reach the forested area, at which point Teal’c and the General pulled ahead, vanishing in the bushes. Sam and the others followed them, but a bit more slowly.

Still, they were close enough to hear when the two made contact.

“The God’s guards are here!”

“Mercy, my lord!”

“Mercy!”

“I am not a follower of the false god Apophis. You have nothing to fear from us,” Teal’c announced in the kind of voice that carried over a battlefield.

“Oh, no! It’s the Betrayer!”

“Mercy!”

“Stay faithful, brothers! Our Lord will protect us!”

The General’s voice cut through the desperate cries: “Kind of famous, are you, Teal’c? Or should that be infamous?”

“Oh, no! The God-Killer is here!”

“SG-1!”

“We are doomed!”

“Merciful God, save us!”

Sam couldn’t help grimacing when she rounded a particularly large tree and saw the clearing - where four men were on their knees, begging, in front of the General and Teal’c.

“Well, that brings back memories,” Daniel commented behind her. “You really need to stop making such bad first impressions, Jack.”

“Hey!” the General protested. “It’s not my fault Apophis made us the bogeymen!”

Daniel nodded and walked past Teal’c and the General to address the terrified former slaves. “Don’t be afraid! We won’t hurt you - we’re here to help you.”

One of the men looked up, a hesitant smile half-forming on his lips. Then his eyes widened, and he gasped, staring past Sam.

She glanced over her shoulder. Oh. Of course, the most loyal slaves of Apophis would be familiar with his former queen’s host.

“I am no longer Amaunet’s host,” Sha’re said as she stepped past Sam. “Taweret has been taken prisoner and the slaves she had been keeping prisoners have been rescued.”

Another of the cowering men looked up. “They are alive?”

“Yes.” Sha’re nodded. “Apophis intended to silence them - and you.”

“We… we knew too much. Secrets that could threaten our god, should his rivals get their hands on us,” the man said.

“You knew that, yet you still summoned him?” The General shook his head.

“We prayed to him.” A third man was raising his head. “And he answered our prayers.”

“By shooting at your camp. Did you flee?” Daniel asked in a soft voice.

The three men lowered their heads again, and the fourth whimpered. “We were… weak. The others stayed and faced our god’s judgement. We ran,” the first man whispered.

“As soon as we saw the divine ship,” the second added.

Ah. That explained why they had survived.

“You did nothing wrong,” Daniel told them as he crouched down next to the first man. “Apophis didn’t have the right to kill you.”

“He is our god! Our lives are his to use as he deems fit!” the man protested.

Daniel shook his head. “No. Your lives are yours to live. No god has the right to take your lives.”

“He is our god! We belong to him!”

“If he cannot protect his faithful from being taken by others, he is a weak god,” Sha’re said with a sneer. “He has been beaten by SG-1, he has lost his heir and both his queens, and he was defeated in this world as well and his flagship lost.” She pointed in the direction of Bright Moon. The crash site wasn’t visible from here, but with good binoculars, you could make out the smoke still rising from he wreck. “He has lost any claim he had on you.”

That seemed to rattle the men. Sam saw them exchange glances while they still had their heads lowered. Of course, Sha’re would be familiar with Apophis’s most loyal slaves.

“Did… you defeat him in this world?” the third man asked.

Sam pressed her lips together, and Daniel and Sha’re seemed to hesitate as well.

“The false god was defeated by She-Ra. She challenged him in his palace and killed him to save this world,” Teal’c told them.

“She-Ra…” the first man whispered as he glanced at the others. “We’ve heard of her.”

“The goddess who stormed his palace on Saqqara…” the second man breathed, and the other two slowly nodded.

“She healed everyone, friend and foe alike.”

“Yes, She-Ra did,” Sha’re said. “She protects everyone.”

“And she wants to take you home to your friends and families,” Daniel added. His smile looked a bit embarrassed.

Sam could understand that - Daniel knew as well as she did that Adora wouldn’t like this.

“If the goddess who defeated Apophis commands it…” The first man took a deep breath. “...then we obey.”

The others nodded.

Sam winced. Yes, Adora definitely wouldn’t like this. But trying to tell the former slaves, all of them indoctrinated from birth, that She-Ra wasn’t a goddess could wait until they had taken them back to their home dimension.

*****

Catra eyed the tower in front of her, especially the balcony three-quarters to the top. She could easily climb up there - her claws would leave some cuts and gouges on the surface, but Angella could probably wish the damage repaired, so that was no big deal.

The question was: Should she be doing this? She had never really met Angella before the… Portal. Angella was Glimmer’s mom, and Adora’s… foster mom? Or something. In any case, Catra should just call Adora and let her and Glimmer know that she found the queen who didn’t want to talk to them.

On the other hand, what would Adora do? Stand at the bottom of the tower and yell up? Bring all guards running and her copy? Just demanding to meet Angella hadn’t worked when they had arrived at the palace gates, and Catra didn’t think it would work now either.

Glimmer could teleport up there, of course. But Catra doubted that she would - Once she had stopped bickering with her copy, she had gone off to, well, the closest to her cabin on this Darla. To cry, unless Catra's ears were lying to her, which they weren't. Which meant Bow would be useless as well.

Which left Catra. The former Horde commander who had almost taken Bright Moon once and waged war for years on the Alliance. The one responsible for Angella being here in the first place.

But also the first who had met her and the first who had talked to her since the Portal. And someone who had screwed up far worse than Angella had.

So, Catra had an obligation to help fix this. Even though there was a decent chance that showing up in Angella's second office or whatever was up there would end with the queen having her imprisoned again - well, trying to, at least - and a hundred per cent chance that Adora would be mad at her for doing this.

Sighing, Catra walked up to the wall and unsheathed her claws.

Less than thirty seconds later, she pulled herself up and over the railing of the balcony and peered through the open door. Ah - it was an office. She saw Angella standing at the desk, one hand moving over its surface. Though… Catra narrowed her eyes. That didn't look like an office in use. There were no papers on the desk. And the style of the furniture looked a bit off compared to what Catra was familiar with at the palace. Wait! Those books and memory crystals on the shelf looked familiar. She had seen them before somewhere…

Oh. Her eyes widened. This was *Micah's* office. That made sense.

Catra nodded and stepped through the door. "Angella? We need to talk."

*****

The Lost Dimension Part 7

Unknown Location, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra cleared her throat. “Angella? We need to talk.”

The queen spun around. “You!”

Catra managed not to flinch at the glare aimed at her. Instead, she nodded with a twisted smile. “Yes, me.”

“What are you doing here?”

She hadn’t called the guards. That was a good sign. Or so Catra hoped. She shrugged and said before she could help herself: “Talking to you.”

Angella’s scowl deepened. “You?” she scoffed.

“Yes, me.” Catra shrugged again and wandered over to the desk - keeping it between her and Angella. “I kind of know what you’re going through.” At least, she thought so. If she was wrong… well, Adora would be mad either way.

Angella scoffed again. “You dare? You’re Horde scum!”

But she still hadn’t called for her guards, Catra noted. And she sounded a lot like her daughter right then. Well, except for the slight accent. “I know what it’s like to feel guilty.” And shame. And embarrassment. And self-loathing. And being crazy.

“Guilty? I didn’t conquer a kingdom and then tried to take over the world!” Angella spat. “I defended my world against you!”

Technically, Catra hadn’t conquered a kingdom - well, not while Angella had been around. Salinas and Plumeria had fallen afterwards.

But Angella wasn’t finished. “I didn’t try to destroy the world!”

This time, Catra flinched. She had done that. But she pushed the guilt she felt away and nodded. “Technically, I was trying to change the world - to create a perfect world for me.” With Adora at her side, of course.

And Angella flinched. But her glare grew more intense. “You endangered our world! I had to sacrifice myself to save it!”

“And then you created your own perfect world,” Catra said. “Only, it’s not as perfect as you thought it would be, right?”

Angella pressed her lips together.

“Because no matter how we’d like to fool ourselves, it’s a fake world. Not real.” Catra nodded once more.

“This world is real!” Angella blurted out. “And I didn’t destroy another world for this - this was an empty dimension when I arrived!”

Catra clenched her teeth for a moment. I was crazy, she told herself. “It’s not real. It’s reacting to our thoughts.” She put her hands on the desk - freshly polished, she noted - and leaned forward. “And it won’t ever be real. It will always remain a dream.” A foolish dream.

“No! This is no dream!” Angella yelled.

“That’s why the ‘people’ here act like bots?” Catra scoffed. “Your fake ‘daughter’ is only doing what you want her to do. She is barely more than a puppet, isn’t she?”

“No!” Angella shook her head. “No!”

Catra drew a sharp breath. Time to get serious. “You knew that, though, didn’t you? You always knew she was a fake.” If Angella had actually fooled herself…

“No!”

“And now the real Glimmer is here,” Catra went on, trying not to show how tense she was. “And she is disgusted by this perfect world of yours.”

Angella flung her arm out and swept a stack of books from the desk, scattering them over the floor. “Shut up!”

“And you fear that Micah will be disgusted as well.”

“Shut up!” Angella rounded the table and rushed towards her.

And Catra hissed through clenched teeth. Damn! That had been too much!

She jerked back, hands raising to defend herself, but stopped. Fighting Angella would be… Catra managed to turn with the blow but was still sent stumbling. “Did that…” Another blow to the stomach - she had barely time to tense her muscles - interrupted her, pushing her back a few more steps.

Once more, she almost lashed out in reflex but managed to control herself. She did take a few more steps back, though - Angella was stronger than she had thought. Stronger than Glimmer, in any case. Catra had been hit far worse, though. And she deserved it back then, too.

“Shut up!” And there Angella came again, baring her teeth as she wound up another strike.

Catra twitched but stood her ground, catching another blow to the face. She exaggerated her staggering until her back hit the wall.

“Shut up!” Angella snarled.

OK, enough was enough. Catra literally had her back to the wall. This time, she jerked her head to the side, and Angella’s fist hit the wall instead of her face - and they ended up facing each other up close. “Lashing out won’t solve this,” Catra whispered into Angella’s face. “Trust me, I know.” She bared her teeth in a grin and tried not to wince from the pain of her swollen lips.

“This is all your fault!” Angella drew back her other fist.

Catra deflected the blow. “Not everything. Creating this world is on you,” she spat.

“I wouldn’t be here if not for you!” Angella’s fist was bleeding, but Catra didn’t think the tears in her eyes were because of that.

This time, she caught the blow. She couldn’t have done that with Adora, but Angella was no She-Ra. “Yeah. And I didn’t choose to be raised as a Horde soldier. But I still could have defected.” Like Adora did.

Angella was panting - Catra could feel the woman’s breath on her face. “You were in charge!”

“Yes.” Catra stared at her. “I was.” That was her fault. Her guilt. “And you made this world.”

“I had lost everyone!” And the tears started to fall.

“And I had lost Adora.” Catra clenched her teeth. “It’s not an excuse.” She snorted. “Trust me, I know.”

Angella stared at her. “I’m not like you!”

“No.” Catra chuckled. Once. “But you will be if you don’t stop… this.” She shook her head. “Stop pushing your loved ones away. Trust me, that’s the worst mistake you can make.” Catra knew that very, very well.

Angella blinked through her tears and took a step back before looking away. “You heard Glimmer. They hate me!”

Oh, for…! Catra scoffed. “They love you, you idiot!”

Angella glared at her. Was that progress? “What would you know about *that*?”

That was… "They accepted *me*!" Catra snarled. "At least *you* didn't kill any real people!"

"And why did they accept you after all you did to us?"

"Because Adora's a much better person than I'll ever be," Catra said.

Angella blinked. "This is not - not just - about Adora. You heard what Glimmer said. I made a copy of her! She thinks I replaced her!"

"You did." Catra snorted as Angella glared at her again. If she could admit her guilt, Angella could own up to her own mistakes. "But that doesn't matter. She's your daughter. Micah's your husband. Consort. Whatever. They love you."

Angella looked away again. "They don't know me. Not any more."

"Glimmer's done things she regrets as well. So did Micah." At least Catra assumed so - she wasn't really that close to him. But he had been controlled by Horde Prime's chips during the war and attacked his friends, and Catra knew how that felt.

Angella didn't say anything. Catra waited. She had said what she had wanted to say. Repeating it wouldn't really help. Maybe…

"I created the Horde just to wipe it out," Angella said without looking at her. "Including a copy of you."

Ah. Catra drew a short breath through clenched teeth. "They weren't real people," she said as nonchalantly as she could. "More like… training bots?"

Angella turned her head to stare at her again. "Training bots don't bleed and beg."

"I wouldn't have begged either," Catra told her. She flashed her fangs. "And I'm not that easy to kill. I let you hit me."

Angella scoffed softly in response, and, for a moment, they looked at each other with matching wry, pained grins.

“So…” Catra trailed off. “Do you really think you are worse than me? Or Hordak?”

“Hordak.” Angella pressed her lips together before shaking her head. “No, I don't suppose so.” She straightened. “Very well. I shall have a talk with Glimmer. And with Micah.”

That didn’t sound very enthusiastic to Catra. But it was good enough. The rest was up to Glimmer and the others. Catra had done her good deed for the week or something. Now they just…

She turned her head when a cloud of sparkles appeared on the balcony.

“Mom! We need to talk!” Glimmer exclaimed as she, Adora and Bow were revealed. “I’m… Catra? What are you doing here?”

“Catra?” Adora gasped.

“Hey, Adora!” Catra grinned at her, wincing a little at the pain from her lips.

“You’re hurt!” Adora started towards her.

“Mom! You’re hurt!” Glimmer must have noticed Angella’s bleeding hand. “What… Wait! Did you two fight?”

“No!” Catra said.

“Yes,” Angella said.

Catra glared at her. That was the absolute wrong thing to say!

“Catra!”

“Mom!”

“Why did you fight?”

“Let me heal you - both of you!”

“It wasn’t a fight!” Catra protested. She had let Angella hit her!

But no one was listening to her.

*****

Jack O’Neill shook his head as he watched the former slaves board one of the skiffs that had arrived at their position. Four survivors of over a dozen. The rest of them had been killed by the very god they had created in their minds. There was probably a lesson here.

He turned and saw that Daniel was on his knees and checking the remains of the campsite, if you could call it that - it lacked even a firepit. “Daniel?”

“Just a few more minutes. I’m checking for any tools that they might have created,” his friend replied without looking up from the patch of sandy ground he was searching.

“I think they took everything with them. Not that they had much to begin with,” Jack said.

“We’re in a special dimension, Jack. They might have created tools and other artefacts without being aware of it.” Daniel perked up and raised his hand, holding up what looked like a piece of rock. “Ah!”

“A pet rock?” Jack raised his eyebrows.

Sha’re shook her head with a frown aimed at him but didn’t comment.

“It’s flint!” Daniel replied.

“Yes?” Jack wondered what he was about.

“This couldn’t have formed here naturally - the geology is wrong for flint to form,” Daniel said. “And it has traces of being worked on. So, either someone dropped it here, or it was created by someone thinking that it should be found here. But according to the local Etherians, this area was never settled - that’s why they placed the refugee camp here.”

There is probably a lesson here as well, Jack thought. Of course, the camp they had seen - well, its remains - had been very nice, a small village, not some enclosed tents in the desert, but it certainly had been out of the way from the major kingdoms. On the other hand, the Etherians hadn’t had the best experiences with visitors. First the First Ones, and then Hordak. And this was a world created by an Angella gone rather… extremist, not the real Etheria. A world where the Horde had been exterminated to the last soldier instead of welcomed with open arms after the war had ended.

He pushed the thought away. “So…?” He cocked his head.

“The only one able to do this would have been the former slaves. So, they expected to find flint if they dug around here - which means they are familiar with such campsites.” Daniel beamed at him. “Campsites by fleeing slaves trying to hide from the Goa’uld!”

“Ah.” Jack nodded. “You think they have tales of or even experience with slaves fleeting on their home worlds.” Daniel looked surprised, and Jack snorted. He wasn’t some dumb jock. And he had spent years working with Daniel; you couldn’t help picking up some things.

“Ah, yes, exactly!” Daniel recovered quickly. “And they were thought to be the most loyal slaves of Apophis. So, there might be a bigger culture of dissidents amongst his followers than we expected.”

“That would be nice.” Jack grinned. “I’ll pass it on to the intel weenies. They’ll want to hear all about it from you.”

Daniel smiled, then blinked. “Oh.”

Jack smirked a little. Giving a lecture was one thing, being grilled by spooks looking for clues about the enemy was another. Daniel was familiar with the difference from experience. He patted his friend on the shoulder and went to check on Carter and Entrapta.

The two were focused on their gimmicks, occasionally waving around some sort of antenna. Or a magic wand; Jack couldn’t tell the difference. “So!” he called out. “How much longer do you need before we can leave?”

“We’re almost done, sir,” Carter replied, looking up at him. “We’ve completed the primary scans and are now double-checking some results.”

“Then we can compare them to the data from the destroyed village and find out how much the number of minds affects the shaping effect on this dimension!” Entrapta said, nodding enthusiastically. “Well, we should be able to form a hypothesis, at least, but that’s still progress!”

“Good.” Knowing how dangerous the four rescued former slaves were was important. The last thing Jack wanted was to be caught by another Apophis on the way back to Bright Moon. Or some other monstrosity conjured by someone’s imagination. “Don’t think about Marshmallow Men, by the way.”

Carter chuckled at that, then pressed her lips together and frowned at him. “We won’t, sir.”

He grinned. He still had it.

“We won’t?” Entrapta looked confused. “I’m now thinking about… whatever that is.”

Uh-oh. Jack grimaced. “Ah… Carter can explain. Once you have finished your work here.”

“Right!”

While Entrapta turned back to their scanner, Carter shot him a look through narrowed eyes. Jack shrugged with an apologetic smile. Yeah, that hadn't been smart of him, but, if necessary, Carter could handle distracting Entrapta until they were back in their home dimension. If Entrapta hadn't seen the movie, there shouldn't be any danger, anyway.

No more than from anyone else having stray thoughts. You apparently needed a very focused mind to create anything like a god here.

Though smaller stuff was a different thing, wasn't it? Jack blinked, then grinned and looked at the campsite again. If this were on Earth, in a National Park, there would be…

"Jack!" Daniel exclaimed. "Someone has planted a park ranger sign here! How could… Jack! You just ruined the site!"

Perfect.

*****

By the time they left the palace, Adora was still angry at Catra. Her love had gone off to talk with Angella! Alone! With the person who had had the entire Horde - including Catra - in this dimension executed! And she saw nothing wrong with it!

"I don't know why you are so mad," Catra said.

Adora turned to face her with a scowl. "You know exactly why I am mad!"

"Everything worked out fine." Catra crossed her arms over her chest and raised her head a little. She did that when she felt guilty and didn't want to show it, Adora knew.

"You didn't know that when you sneaked off and climbed the tower! Like… like an assassin! If anyone had seen you…"

Catra scoffed. "As if the guards could have spotted me!"

Adora glanced at the two guards standing at attention at the gate. They were glaring at Catra.

Catra followed her gaze and snorted. “They’re just copies.”

The guards didn’t react to that at all, and Adora pressed her lips together. That was creepy. And Catra was still wrong. “Angella isn’t,” she said.

“Angella didn’t think I was an assassin either.” Cara shrugged.

“She attacked you!” And hurt her!

“It was just a few slaps,” Catra retorted. “I’ve been hit harder in training.”

“That was in the Horde!” Adora spat. And they hadn’t known how wrong that was.

“Or by a little girl,” Catra continued.

“That was Frosta!”

Now, Catra frowned at her. “You healed me.”

“That’s not an excuse for getting hurt!” Adora clenched her teeth. Catra could be so stubborn!

“Hey! Angella attacked me! I didn’t attack her.”

“You said you let her hit you!” Adora almost grabbed Catra but stopped before she touched her.

“Well… yes, I did.” Catra flashed her fangs. “But I knew I could take it.”

“Did you?” Adora narrowed her eyes. They had talked about that in cadet training! “What if she had used her powers? What if she had used a weapon?” Angella could have created anything in this dimension.

“I wouldn’t have let her hit me then!” Catra shook her head.

“You couldn’t have known that!” Adora clenched her teeth again. Why was her love so stubborn?

“It was a calculated risk.”

That was also from cadet training. And the Horde standards for what was an acceptable risk were far below the Alliance ones. “You didn’t have to take the risk at all! Or alone!” Catra looked away, and Adora bit her lower lip. “Why did you do it?” she asked in a softer voice.

“She was here because of me,” Catra whispered.

Oh… Adora sighed and reached out to hug Catra. And resisted the brief urge to shake some sense into her. She took a deep breath and calmed down. “That doesn’t mean you have to get hurt.” That was wrong! And two wrongs didn’t make a right!

“I didn’t plan to get hurt.”

“You let her hit you.”

“Well… no plan survives contact with the enemy?”

Adora didn’t need to see Catra’s face to know she was weakly grinning. She hugged her a bit more tightly, though. Just to make her point. “Idiot.”

“That’s my line.”

“Not when you’re being the idiot.”

“Someone had to talk sense into Angella. And, well…” Catra sighed - Adora felt her taking a deep breath. “...I’ve been there. I’ve made mistakes like she did. And worse.”

“Oh.” Adora blinked. She hadn’t considered that. “But we all made mistakes,” she whispered. “I did, Glimmer did…”

“Not like mine,” Catra cut her off. “And Glimmer? You think she could have talked things out with Angella?”

Adora bit her lip again and felt her face heat up. “She’s not a teenager anymore.”

“Could have fooled me.” Catra snorted again. “And you were feeling too guilty to handle this.”

“Me?” Adora drew back and stared at her.

Catra nodded. “You feel guilty for letting her sacrifice herself in your place.”

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it again, and glared at Catra’s smirk. “You feel guilty as well.” Or more.

“Yes. But I don’t know Angella. Not like you and Glimmer do. And she doesn’t know me. We’re kind of… more professional.”

Adora snorted. “So professional, you had a fight.”

“It wasn’t a fight - I let her hit me,” Catra retorted at once. “And it worked, didn’t it? She’s coming back home.”

Adora reluctantly nodded.

“Everything worked out fine.” Catra’s smirk grew.

Adora rolled her eyes. “That doesn’t mean you were right to do it.”

“Sure it does!”

“It just means you were lucky.” And luck ran out sooner or later.

Catra shrugged, still grinning.

Adora again wanted to shake her. She could tell that this was a facade - she knew Catra better than anyone else. “We’ll talk about

this again, later," she said. When she could prepare better. Catra couldn't go on like this.

Catra grimaced, and Adora couldn't help grinning. A little.

*****

"...so, the Queen's coming back with us?" The General sounded a little doubtful, in Samantha Carter's opinion. Quite justified, of course - when they had set out to recover the missing former slaves of Apophis, Queen Angella had been quite forceful in her refusal to talk, much less come with the group. Things had apparently changed drastically in their absence.

"What made her change her opinion?" Daniel asked.

"We had a talk," Catra said.

"They had a fight," Adora added.

"It wasn't a fight!" Catra protested. "Whatever - the point is, Angella is coming back with us. Probably as soon as she and Glimmer finish their own talk." She shrugged. "Then we can finally leave this dimension behind."

"But it's such an interesting dimension! Anything is possible here! You can alter the very fabric of reality with a thought!" Entrapta piped up.

"Like Jack demonstrated when he created a signpost as a joke," Daniel said with a wry smile.

"Ah." Adora nodded.

"But that's just scratching the surface," Entrapta said. "You could do that with magic in our dimension. Castaspella could probably teach you a spell for that." Sam noted that the General stopped grinning at hearing that. "Or a magitech device that created materials out of the available molecules in the air or something," Entrapta went on. "But here, we can change the laws of physics -

the fundamental rules that define the universe - with our minds! Imagine what we could do if we change the gravitational constant into a variable!”

Sam did - and struggled not to wince at the potential consequences. “I fear that we lack the necessary data to conduct such an experiment in a safe manner.”

Everyone else except for Entrapta grimaced.

Entrapta, though, nodded. “Yes! Which is why we will have to run many experiments here to gather data - we can build up safely to the major experiments. Well, mostly safely - some risks remain, of course, because we’re breaking new ground. And, I guess, because the entire dimension is so malleable. Even small distractions could ruin our data.”

Or our lives, Sam thought, smiling weakly. “That would take a long time, though,” she pointed out. “And we have many other, urgent projects we have to finish.”

Entrapta blinked. “Right. Hordak and Loki wouldn’t be happy if we just dropped the research into their projects. And neither would be the Alliance, I guess, if we stopped research and development. Although! If we could use this dimension to research things…”

“That would have to be done safely,” Sam reminded her. “Which would take a long time.”

Entrapta sighed. “I guess so.”

The General clapped his hands together. “So, no unravelling the universe for now! Neither this one nor our own!”

Sam nodded in agreement. Although Entrapta was correct about the potential this dimension offered to research. Maybe once the war against the Go’auld was over, they could pursue this. Although… “We will have to keep this dimension under surveillance, though. We have to assume that Apophis is aware of what kind of research was done here.” Even if Taweret might have

tried to hide it, he would have had spies amongst the Jaffa to inform him. "And while we have taken control of Beta and captured Taweret, we cannot exclude the possibility that Apophis will attempt to continue those experiments."

"Great." The General sighed. "We'll have to find a way to observe a dimension where our mere presence will change it."

"That's not actually that uncommon," Daniel commented. "Especially when interacting with another culture."

"Or in physics," Sam added. Although the observer effect usually wasn't as massive - and dangerous - as it was here.

"Right. So, let's think about that. Once we are back home," the General said.

"Well, we can keep scanning for foreign visitors to this dimension," Entrapta said. "That wouldn't be very exciting, though - and it would be unfair to Beta if she were limited to observing and couldn't do any experimenting."

"Oh, yeah. We don't want the mad scientist bot to grow bored, do we?" The General nodded.

He was using sarcasm, but Sam nodded in agreement. "I fear Beta might show some, ah, initiative if she were bored."

"Right. Carter, find a way to keep the bot busy without breaking our universe, OK?"

"Yes, sir."

"Oh, there's lots Beta can help us with!" Entrapta cheered. "We've got so many projects, she is bound to find something she likes!"

"Yeah…" The General gave Sam a look, and she nodded again.

Message received.

“Though…” Entrapta frowned. “If Angella’s coming with us, what about her people here?”

“They’re not real people. They’re like dumb bots,” Catra said with a shrug.

Entrapta frowned at her. “That doesn’t mean we shouldn’t care about them! We can’t just abandon them!”

The General looked like he disagreed with that opinion. As did Catra. But Sam wasn’t sure. “We don’t know how sentient or sapient they are,” she said.

“Exactly!” Entrapta beamed at her. “We need to know more before we just… leave them to fade.” She frowned again. “No one should be left alone to slowly disappear like that.”

It might be a case of anthropomorphism, influenced by her contact with Alpha, Beta and Emily, but Sam had to agree with that. And Adora seemed to have some doubts as well.

“They wouldn’t be alone,” Catra objected. “They would be all together.”

“But without Angella,” Entrapta retorted, shaking her head. “Their queen. Their mom, in a way.”

“If they might be sapient - or even just sentient - then we can’t just abandon them,” Daniel said. “That would be cruel.”

“That’s something the Goa’uld would do,” Sha’re added.

Teal’c nodded curtly.

The General sighed again.

*****

Catra rolled her eyes and leaned against the parked skiff. “Would you want Angella to stay here for the rest of her life then? Huh?”

“Well…” Entrapta frowned. “That wouldn’t be fair. But she’s responsible for them since she created them. You can’t just make a bot and then abandon them.”

“She also created the Horde here - and then had all of them executed,” Catra pointed out.

Daniel winced at that, as did Sam, but Entrapta nodded. “She did. And that wasn’t right. You shouldn’t create something just to destroy it. Except when it’s a target dummy, of course. But you don’t make target dummies that could feel - that would be really wrong. Anyway! Just because it was wrong to create the Horde and then destroy it doesn’t mean that abandoning this Etheria is OK.”

Adora nodded. “Two wrongs don’t make a right.”

Catra clenched her teeth. “We don’t even know if those people can feel anything.” Or if they were actually people. “They didn’t react like real people would have - you know that; we fought them.”

“People with cognitive limitations are still people,” Daniel objected. He pushed his glasses up his nose. “And they did feel pain.”

Briefly, Catra thought. She didn’t say that out loud, of course. This was already a tense discussion. And Adora was getting worked up - Catra could tell. Well, more worked up; her love was already worked up about Catra’s talk with Angella. She pushed the guilt she felt for worrying Adora away. “Or they just acted like they were expected to. Like simulations. For training.” Like the enemies they had been facing during cadet training.

“Well…” Daniel smiled in that ‘apologetic way of his that told Catra she wouldn’t like what he was saying. “If the simulation is good enough to look real, how can we tell it apart from real feelings?”

“That’s a good question!” Entrapta nodded. “If they were bots, we could analyse their decision matrices and check if they feel something or just follow their programming. But that’s a bit tricky

here - we might be influencing the results by changing them as we examine them. Without realising it." She blinked. "Oh, and it would also be difficult since they aren't bots with a decision matrix but people with a brain."

"It would be very unethical," Sam agreed.

"And if we cannot determine if they are sentient, we have to assume they are. Anything else wouldn't be ethical," Daniel said.

"Why is the ethical answer always the one that creates more problems?" Jack complained.

"Do we actually know if they will fade without Angella?" Adora asked, biting her lower lip.

"No, we don't," Entrapta said. "Not for sure. But our data does indicate that without an external, meaning a foreign sapient influence shaping it, over time, this dimension returns to its basic undetermined state. At least, we haven't noticed anyone created here affecting the dimension as we do. Although we cannot exclude the possibility that our scanners aren't calibrated to detect such a hypothetical influence."

"Without proof of that, we still have to assume that they don't have such a stabilising influence on their surroundings." Sam sounded as if she didn't like that any more than Catra did.

And while she was right, the conclusion was still wrong. "Angella is the only one to stabilise this world," Catra said. "Should she be trapped here just because we can't be sure that the people here are people?"

Adora opened her mouth, only to close it after a second without saying anything. Idiot.

None of the others said anything either. Typical.

"We cannot demand this of her," Daniel said after a moment.

"Why not?" Catra shrugged. "If she's responsible for them, and we can't assume that they are just bots, and she's the only one to save them from fading away…?" She trailed off and raised her eyebrows at him. "Or are we just expecting her to sacrifice herself for this world instead of demanding it?" Sacrifice herself *again*.

Once more, everyone was silent for a moment.

"And what if the people here are just… programmed figments or something?" Jack added. "She'd sacrifice herself for nothing."

"That's a good point," Daniel said hesitantly. "Staying here, alone, surrounded by her own creations, isn't healthy. Would it be ethical to expect Angella to sacrifice her own mental health based on the mere assumption that her creations are sentient?"

No, Catra thought. That would render her efforts to talk sense into Angella pointless.

"But what if they are?" Entrapta asked. "They act like they are."

"We need to find out," Adora said.

"But how?" Sam asked. "This dimension's unique circumstances render a Turing Test useless since the test subjects are directly or indirectly linked to a sapient mind."

"And even if they aren't sapient, they could still be sentient," Daniel pointed out.

"So are animals, but we eat them," Jack retorted.

Catra bit her lower lip. This was… There was something… she almost had it. Ah! "They're not like animals," she said.

"Of course not," Adora said.

Catra frowned at her. "No, I mean… they weren't just created by Angella - they're still linked to her. When we started talking to her, the guards, the copies, they didn't react. Do you think Angella

created them like that? With such a… a blind spot? Or did she change them as soon as we started talking?"

"Oh!" Entrapta tilted her head. "She wouldn't have programmed them like that when she created them since she wouldn't have expected such a situation. Or would she?"

"It's not impossible, but… unlikely, I think," Sam said.

Yes. Catra nodded. "So, if their minds, their personality, can be changed on a whim, especially their memories, are they truly people? Or just, like, extensions of Angella's thoughts?"

"Manipulating someone's memories doesn't rob them of their personhood," Daniel objected.

"But what if they don't have a personality without someone imagining it?" Catra retorted. "If they fade without Angella, and they were created by Angella, and constantly adapted by her imagination…" She gestured at their surroundings. "That sounds like a dream that fades when you wake up."

"How poetic," Jack commented. She narrowed her eyes at him, and he shrugged. "But a good point. It's like we're in someone's dream, and talk about not letting them wake up so the dream never fades."

"That's stretching things quite a bit," Daniel said. "A dream we can interact with, and affect without imagination."

"That's still a dream." Jack grinned. "And you can't keep dreaming forever."

"It's still a hypothesis," Daniel pointed out. "Based on our assumptions."

He was right, technically, but the more Catra thought about this, the surer she was that this was sort of a dream. A dimension formed by your imagination, lasting only as long as you thought

about it - as long as you were present. As long as your mind was occupied with it.

Yes, that was like a dream. And no matter what you were dreaming, sooner or later, you had to wake up.

“But…” Entrapta looked distraught. “Even if they aren’t real people, they still act and think as if they have real feelings, even if they need Angella for that. And they will react to Angella leaving. Especially if it takes time for them to fade.”

“Angella can change them so they don’t react,” Catra said.

“That wouldn’t be right either!” Entrapta protested. “They would be left like that for… days, maybe weeks depending on how long it takes established structures and forms to fade here - we still haven’t worked out if the age of the changes affects this.”

“Angella leaving with us isn’t something that they wouldn’t expect,” Adora said. “Princesses leave their kingdom to visit others. That’s normal.”

“But they wouldn’t be cut off from any contact,” Entrapta said. “Not since we invented communicators. Here, Angella would effectively vanish. And they couldn’t contact her if they start fading.”

“Well, then it would be Glimmer’s - the copy’s - problem,” Catra muttered. “She’s her successor.”

“That’s not how…” Adora trailed off. “What if we copy Angella?”

Catra blinked. Now, that would solve this stupid problem, wouldn’t it?

*****

“You want to make a copy of me?”

Queen Angella didn't sound very enthusiastic in Jack O'Neill's opinion. He wouldn't have been, either, if someone wanted to make a copy of himself. Especially if it was a snake or Loki.

Entrapta, though, nodded with a beaming smile. “Yes! So this world still has an Angella when you're gone - I mean, when you're gone with us.”

“Just in case your, ah, world depends on you,” Adora added. Her smile was obviously forced. “So your copy either keeps it stable, or…” She trailed off and bit her lower lip.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Or keeps them company while they disappear with the entire world.”

Jack almost snorted. At least Catra didn't hide what she thought about the entire affair.

Angella glared at her, then at the rest of the group. “And what do you expect will happen?”

“We don't know,” Carter replied. “There are multiple potential outcomes and we cannot say which is the most likely.”

“So you are hedging your bets?” Angella raised her eyebrows. “Do you think I might not leave if I fear that the entire world will fade without my presence? Or do you assume I will not return if there's already a replacement present here?”

“What?” Entrapta looked genuinely surprised. “No! We just thought about the people here.”

Yeah, Jack was sure that this had never crossed her mind. The others, though… Adora, of course, only now realised how this looked, but Catra definitely had thought about this part. Daniel looked guilty and embarrassed for getting caught, not shocked, and Sha're looked as if she expected that.

Glimmer, though, scowled. “What do you mean, returning here?”

Angella turned to stare at her. “Do not take my decision for granted, Glimmer.”

“You can't leave us again!” Glimmer blurted out. “You can't!”

Angella flinched. “I am not planning to,” she said, sounding more than a little guilty. “I was just commenting on this… plan of yours.”

“I didn’t know about that plan either!” Glimmer protested.

“We came up with that to ensure that we don't abandon the people here,” Entrapta told her. “It was the best we could think of, based on the data we have.”

“Making a copy of me was the best you could think of?” Angella frowned at her.

“You made a copy of everyone else,” Catra cut in. “So, it's not as if it's something special.” Angella glared at her but Catra shrugged. “Goose, gander, you know.”

“Do what you want. I will not take part in it.” Angella walked past them, to the edge of the small area that served as their camp at Bright Moon.

Glimmer shot them a look and turned to follow her, but Catra reached out. “Stay! You know her best.”

“What?”

“We need you to help with this,” Catra explained. “Or we'll get a weird copy.”

“Making a copy of my mom is weird already!”

“She made a copy of you.”

“That doesn't make it any better!” Glimmer snapped.

“Just imagine Angella as you remember her,” Entrapta spoke up. “We all do that. Then we should be able to create her.”

“Or we end up with a mad goddess,” Jack commented.

“That would only be the result if we imagine her as such, Jack,” Daniel told him.

Well, from, his brief acquaintance with her, she seemed mad enough for two queens to Jack. He didn't say that, though. This was already taking too long. “Let's do this, then,” he said instead.

Most of the others closed their eyes. Jack didn't. He just tried to think of Angella, but nicer. Like Adora. Not as powerful, though. Just in case.

Minutes passed without anything happening. Jack was about to make a comment about plans failing when suddenly, a sparkling cloud appeared in the middle of the group, bright enough to make him curse and shield his eyes.

By the time he managed to see more than colourful spots, Angella stood there. Smiling kindly.

“Glimmer. It's been so long!” And she hugged her. “So, you’ve finally found your missing mother! And you’ll take her home with you! I am so happy for you!”

“Ah, yes…” Glimmer's smile looked more like a grimace. As did Adora's. Entrapta was looking at her scanner. Bow was looking like he wanted to be anywhere but here.

Well, Jack shared the sentiment. This Angella was creepy. Like some Stepford Wife Queen. He turned and walked over to stand near Angella.

The real queen didn't even glance back at her copy, though he was sure she had noticed her appearance - she couldn't have missed the blinding light.

But she didn't say anything, and neither did Jack. They just stood there, waiting, until he heard steps behind him and turned to see Adora approaching them.

“Uh… we're ready to return. The, ah, copy has gone to the palace,” she said.

“Very well.” Angella nodded with a cool expression.

“Do you, ah, want to say goodbye to…”

“No.” Angella cut her off. “Let us finally be off.”

“Yeah.” Jack had had his fill of this creepy copycat dimension. “Let's go home.”

He was already reaching for the communicator to call the base when they started to walk over to the rest of the group.

A minute later, the world around them faded, and they found themselves back in Beta’s main chamber. Hordak was peering at them through some sort of scanner, with Beta hovering behind him.

And Jack had never been as happy as to enter an Ancient research base as right now. The base was run by a crazy and creepy AI, their experiments were morally and ethically questionable, but at least the crew were real people, not figments, and reality wasn't reacting to stray thoughts as if you were god.

Jack had had his fill of gods as well.

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The Lost Dimension Part 8

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

They were back in their home dimension! Finally! Adora almost sighed with relief as she looked around, but she noticed Angella was looking like she was frozen except for her eyes darting back and forth as she took in the room. Oh - Angella had said that…

"According to the scanners, there is no residual extra-dimensional energy," Hordak announced.

"Hordak!" Angella spat, tensing up.

Adora winced. They had told Angella about Hordak, but maybe they should have prepared her a bit better for meeting her old enemy. On the other hand, what if she had refused to come?

"Queen Angella." Hordak nodded at her, then looked at his display. "The data explains several of the readings we got from the dimension. And the timeline checks out. It seems that time isn't amongst the constants affected by the dimension's nature, then."

"Oh?" Entrapta quickly moved to his side. "You managed to get data about the dimension's past?"

"I extrapolated a ripple effect from the divergences in the base readings," Hordak started to explain.

"Oh!"

Both seemed to be ignoring Angella, who was glaring at them. Adora saw that Sam looked like she really wanted to join them but didn't dare to. What a mess! At least the former slaves were taken away by the guards.

"Welcome back, Adora, Jack O'Neill." Beta appeared in front of them and bowed.

“Alpha!” Angella tensed up even more, almost snarling at the projection.

Right - she knew Alpha. Both the base and the bot. And she probably didn't have good memories of either. Adora winced.

But before she could say something, Beta spoke up. “I am not Alpha. I am Beta. Alpha is in charge of biological research. I focus on extradimensional research.” She cocked her head sideways. “Are you one of the original test subjects of Alpha? The data I was given seems to indicate that.”

Angella’s glare intensified, and Adora saw she was clenching her bared teeth.

“What data?” Glimmer asked. “We didn’t have any idea… Hordak?”

Hordak looked up. “When I was informed about Queen Angella’s presence in the other dimension, I requested all the data we had on her. If it became necessary to extract her in an emergency, the data might have been helpful for calibrating the system.”

Extract her… “You planned to kidnap her?” Adora blurted out. Like he had - with Light Hope’s help - kidnapped her?

Hodark frowned at her. “Only on your orders as the Supreme Commander of the Alliance.”

Ah. Adora nodded, then winced again. That still sounded bad! And now it made her look like she would have kidnapped Angella!

“Not on mine?” Glimmer asked, glaring at Hordak.

He faced her. “Your rank relative to Angella’s is a little doubtful at the moment.”

“What do you…?” Glimmer blinked. “Oh.”

And next to Adora, Catra sighed. “Did you really only realise now that with Angella back, there are two Queens of Bright Moon?”

“I did!” Glimmer protested.

“But you did not consider all the implications,” Angella said, in a tone that took Adora back to one of Angella’s lessons at the start of her time in the Alliance.

“I was more concerned with getting you back home than politics!” Glimmer spat, and, for a moment, she, too, reminded Adora of that time.

“I see.”

And now Glimmer was clenching her teeth. This was all going wrong! They had found Angella, saved her - from Apophis’s attack - and were taking her home; they should celebrate instead of fighting!

“Royal family drama!” Jack muttered. “It’s a good thing we didn’t take any journalists with us!”

“Journalists?” Angella was quick to turn to him, Adora noted.

“People who report the news to the public,” Jack explained with a too-innocent smile.

Angella frowned at him for a moment. “You talk as if you would take such people with you on a combat mission.”

“Well…” Jack’s smile widened. “On Earth, we’re used to journalists reporting from war zones. Unlike the Princess Alliance. So, there’s a bit of a dispute about the whole thing.”

“I thought you liked not having to deal with the press, Jack,” Daniel commented. “Did you change your opinion?”

Jack frowned at him. This was just him being contrarian, then, Adora realised.

“I see.” Angella didn’t scoff, but her expression showed what she thought of that. She turned to Glimmer. “Nevertheless, we should discuss this in private.”

Adora suppressed another relieved sigh.

Then Angella continued: “And with Adora, of course.”

Oh, no!

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“...and the readings here indicate that the other dimension - we really need to find a good name for it, I think, but we probably should ask Angella what she wants it called since she basically created its most distinct area. It would be rude to name it ourselves, wouldn’t it?”

“Yes.” Samantha Carter nodded at Entrapta’s question, even though she doubted that Angella really cared about the dimension she had been trapped in. Although she could be mistaken - she hadn’t met Angella before this, and any second-hand information had obviously been voided by the changes being stranded in another dimension had inflicted on the woman. In any case, it wouldn’t hurt to be polite. And it could hurt to be rude, a small voice added in the back of her mind. Angella had wiped out the Horde in the other dimension, after all. To a man.

“OK! Anyway, the data indicates that the other dimension is free from foreign influences now - we haven’t picked up any changes induced by travellers. Unfortunately, we can’t tell yet if the area that forms Etheria is stable or if it’s started to fade but at such a slow rate that we cannot detect it at this point. And unless the fading rate is growing exponentially, it will be a while until we can detect it. It’s not helping that we lack a solid base rate since it was in constant but minimal flux before this. Actually, this might be the first time the dimension hasn’t been influenced by a sapient mind from another dimension since Angella appeared there, so this might possibly be totally unprecedented! And given

how malleable the entire dimension is, it's theoretically possible that by creating a second Angella, and the desire to stabilise the dimension, we might have changed the constants of the dimension so that's actually possible - a sort of self-sustaining change lasting past out departure. We might not have created a new dimension, but we might have irrevocably altered one!" Entrapta beamed.

Sam blinked, sorting out the relevant points from her friend's slightly rambling talk. "In theory, it might be possible." Mainly because anything was possible in the other dimension.

"We lack the data to tell for certain. And barring positive proof that the affected area is reverting to its basic, undefined state, we will not be able to exclude the possibility that the decay rate is too low to be detected by our scanners," Hordak pointed out.

"If the rate of decay is so low that we can't detect it, then for all practical purposes, the dimension would be stable," Sam retorted. Civilisations could rise and fall - alien civilisations - in such a timespan.

"Unless there are trigger points after which the rate sharply rises. Or cascading effects," Hordak said. "Just because a system looks stable for a long time does not mean that it actually is stable."

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "But we can probably improve our scanners if it takes so long!"

"Even that still would not provide us with proof but merely increase the probability that the dimension's changes are stable," Hordak said.

They were mincing words and technicalities now. Sam was familiar with that kind of argument - and she didn't like it. "We should focus on the practical side."

Entrapta nodded. "Yes! Who knows, maybe we'll detect changes soon - although that would be bad, of course."

"If that turns out to be the case, would Angella be available to return to the dimension to restore it?" Beta asked. "That would result in far more useable data, I believe."

"Oh… We can ask her, I think," Entrapta said. "But Glimmer was kind of mad at the idea." She bit her lower lip. "So… I'm not sure?"

"She might mistake such a request for an attempt to banish her again, especially in light of the current crisis of succession," Hordak said. "It would remove her as a claimant to Bright Moon's throne."

Entrapta frowned. "I don't think Glimmer wants her mom gone so she can be queen."

Sam shook her head. "I don't think so either." Sam was sure Glimmer wouldn't want that. A number of kings and queens, historical royalty on Earth, at least, would have jumped at such a ploy, but not Glimmer. Sam might not know Angella, but she knew Glimmer.

Hordak nodded, but Sam couldn't tell if he agreed or merely acknowledged the statement. "It would be better if they could come to an agreement supported by both," he said. "Disputes over the succession often have a disruptive effect on a kingdom, and since Bright Moon is the leading kingdom in the Princess Alliance, with proportionate influence in the Alliance against the Goa'uld, any such disruption would negatively affect the war effort."

Sam tried really hard not to answer that statement with a comment the General would have made about 'realpolitik'. Hordak might not be a warlord anymore, but while he might have lost the ambition, he hadn't lost the cold calculating views fitting the position. He wasn't wrong, though - if Angella replaced Glimmer as Queen of Bright Moon, who knew how that would influence the Alliance? Her actions in the other dimension might lead to a push for a much harsher way to wage war - something many people on

Earth and in the Alliance would agree with, Sam knew. Maybe even the General.

But she had no doubt that Adora would disagree, quite strongly, with such a push. And that would cause more issues.

If Bright Moon were a democracy… She shook her head. They had to deal with the world as it was, not as they would like it to be. She could only hope that Bright Moon had procedures in place to settle such a situation. If not, things were bound to get messy; history provided countless examples of how monarchies fared in such situations.

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Alliance Base 'Gateway', PU-9623, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Why did we have to leave the research base?"

"Because I am not holding a private talk where Beta can overhear everything we say, Glimmer."

Catra nodded in approval. Angella might be… traumatised, but she wasn't stupid.

Glimmer clenched her teeth and turned to frown at Catra. "And why are you here?"

"Because I'm not letting Adora deal with this by herself," Catra told her with a toothy grin.

Glimmer frowned some more and then looked at her mother.

"She might have some insight to offer about some of the matters we are to discuss." Angella didn't shrug, but she sounded as if she had.

Catra had to give her props for managing to dismiss both Glimmer's unspoken appeal and Catra's presence.

“I'm not sure we should discuss politics here, or now,” Adora said. “That seems something we should discuss back home - in Bright Moon.” Her expression was bland, but Catra could tell that she was not comfortable here. Well, she shouldn't be.

“Yes!” Glimmer agreed at once, smiling at her. “We need to discuss things with Dad. And we need to look for precedents in the archives.”

“There are no precedents,” Angella told her. “I founded the kingdom when I became its first queen.” ‘And you should have considered that before you spoke’ was left unsaid, but Catra heard it perfectly anyway - in Shadow Weaver's voice.

She clenched her teeth. Shadow Weaver was dead. And they weren't discussing her and Adora's upbringing here.

Bow nodded. “Yes. A unique situation on Etheria.”

“But the coronation we attended after you were gone… that was a tradition,” Adora said. “Wasn't it?”

“I set the tradition,” Angella told her. “Back when I ascended to the throne. I didn't expect to rule as long as I did. Things were… more dangerous back then. And I wasn't aware of everything Alpha had done to me.”

“Oh.” Adora closed her mouth before saying anything else.

Glimmer pressed her lips together. “Dad should get a voice anyway.”

“We're not deciding anything without him,” Angella told her with a sigh so soft, Catra's ears almost missed it. “But we need to discuss the salient points of the matter so that I can consider it properly. I shall not be rushed into such decisions while missing crucial knowledge.”

Catra nodded in agreement again. That made sense. A few of her more… questionable decisions would have been different if she'd

had better intel.

“What do you want to know?” Glimmer crossed her arms with a slight huff.

“Do you wish to remain queen?”

Glimmer blinked, apparently surprised. “I am willing to do my duty,” she replied after a second. “For our kingdom. I have done so ever since you… disappeared.”

“That doesn't answer the question,” Angella told her. “I've never doubted that you'd do your duty; I have raised you, after all. But do you *want* to be queen?” Glimmer hesitated, and Angella went on: “Back during the war against the Horde, you preferred commanding and fighting in the field to ruling.”

“I can do both - I did both!” Glimmer protested. “That's how things are done. A princess defends their people with her power - you taught me that!”

“It is not about what you can do, or what you should do, but what you want to do,” Angella corrected her.

Catra glanced at Adora. Her love was frowning, but probably not because she had realised that this was a lesson she needed to learn as well.

And Glimmer wasn't happy. “Oh, now what I want is suddenly important? Before, it was always duty this, responsibility that, and suddenly, you want to know what I want?” She glared at Angella with bared teeth.

Adora grimaced at that. Bow did as well, and Catra managed not to wince. Maybe she shouldn't have insisted on tagging along. Bow seemed like he wanted to be elsewhere as well - but he stood behind Glimmer, one hand on her shoulder.

Angella pressed her lips together, probably reining in her temper - the similarity between her and Glimmer was quite obvious right

then. After a deep breath, she replied: “Based on what I heard so far, you did well as queen, handling both Bright Moon’s internal affairs and foreign diplomacy.”

“The kingdom's still standing,” Catra added. Both of them glared at her, and Adora frowned, but it was worth it.

“We beat the Horde and we'll beat the Goa'uld,” Glimmer said.

And figure out how to deal with Earth afterwards, Catra silently added.

“I'm still waiting for an answer, Glimmer. What do you *want*?”

Glimmer ground her teeth. “I don't know! I want you back, with me, with Dad! Like it was before!”

For the first time since they had arrived in this room, Angella looked taken aback. “Glimmer…” she whispered, then straightened and nodded.

“And I don't want you to go back to that stupid fake world with the stupid fake copy of me!” Glimmer spat.

Angella frowned in return. Once again, she seemed to struggle with her temper. “I see.”

“Do you?” Glimmer scoffed. “You said you might return to this dimension!”

“I said that the possibility shouldn't be excluded,” Angella retorted. It sounded like an excuse.

“Always keep an escape route open,” Catra said. Angella glared at her again, but Catra met her eyes with a smile. She understood wanting to be able to retreat, to go back to a safe place, where things made sense. And where you didn't have to face your past mistake - or the threat of making new ones.

But she also understood that whether Angella was doing it deliberately or not, she was also threatening to leave Glimmer again. And she knew what that kind of threat did to you.

So she bared her teeth. “But you can't escape this. We won't let you.”

Angella kept glaring at her for a moment longer, then looked away.

“So, how are things in Bright Moon? I assume even though the Alliance was victorious, there were significant changes as a result of the war against the Horde.”

Catra grinned as Angella changed the subject. She couldn't escape this discussion, but they could continue it later.

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Refugee Camp, PU-9623, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Alright!” Jack O'Neill nodded at the guards stationed at the entrance while the gates swung up before turning to the four former slaves standing behind him. “Sorry for the delay, but checking you for any transdimensional sickness took a while.” He smiled. “But your families are in the camp here.” With guards placed nearby, both for their security and the Alliance's - these were, after all, former slaves Apophis had picked for being loyal. Not even Adora had argued much against keeping an eye on them in case they were still loyal to their false god.

The men slowly nodded to him - none of them tried to bow, which was good, though a few dipped a bit low - but clearly were already watching for familiar faces amongst the gathering civilians.

And so were the people inside the camp. “Mata!” one cried out. “Mata!”

“Ahak!”

One woman ran toward the group - toward one of the men - Jack had brought, and there came the hugging, crying and babbling. Jack smiled at the display. It was similar to seeing released P.O.W.s reunite with their families.

“Kuni!”

“Sirtak!”

And others found their loved ones thought dead. More tearful reunions with the people they had managed to bring back from the Bizarro Dimension. Which was a fitting name, even if the others disagreed.

But Jack also saw others look around, hopeful smiles fading, turning to grief and tears, when they didn't see their missing loved ones, and his smile turned a little grim. That would hurt the most - realising that your family was dead as you had believed, right after you got your hopes up that you had been wrong. That must feel as if you had lost them twice.

“We should have handled this better,” he muttered as he watched dozens - mostly women with children - turn away from the laughing lucky ones. Not that there was a good way to tell people their family member had died. But there were ways that weren't as bad.

“Yes, we should have,” Daniel agreed next to him. “I should have predicted this.”

“It's not your fault,” Jack reassured him. Jack might not be Daniel's official team leader any more, but he was still responsible for him and the others. Especially with Adora and Glimmer distracted by the mess with Angella. This was Jack's fault.

Daniel looked like he disagreed but slowly nodded. “We need more people with the experience and training to handle traumatised victims of the Goa'uld,” he said. “And we need to take them with us on such missions.”

More people to lift, feed and protect, in other words. But Daniel was right - they needed specialists for that. Combat troops weren't trained for this. On the other hand, Jack wasn't sure if he wanted more civilians on combat missions. That tended to create friction no one needed. The Peace Corps had no place in the Marine Corps. Although… "We'll have to check with the Princess Alliance."

"Oh, yes!" Daniel nodded. "They probably have people with the experience in their forces. And the princesses are expected to handle both combat and such matters. Well, the ruling princesses, at least."

Using heads of state for handling rescued civilians in a combat zone… As much as it made sense, it still felt weird to Jack. Not that he'd mind having another magical powerhouse along on a combat mission.

He shrugged. "Well, we're done here." The crowd was dispersing, splitting up into the different families clustered around the survivors. "We should…" He trailed off as he saw a group walking towards him, Kuta, one of the unofficial leaders - or were they official by now? - amongst them.

"General O'Neill." Kuta addressed him. "As the goddess promised, you brought our missing people back." He bowed deeply. "Thank you."

"Ah, yeah…" Jack grimaced as the others with Kuta bowed as well. "I'm sorry we could not save everyone."

"It is a miracle anyone survived the anger of Apophis," Kuta said. "The goddess brought him low, though."

"She-Ra cut him down," Jack agreed. "Though that wasn't the Apophis you knew - the Apophis here is different." Much weaker, for one.

"Taweret sent your people to another dimension, one filled with people very similar to us yet different," Daniel added. "Their

Apophis was defeated, but ours still remains."

Jack didn't think the people surrounding them understood what alternate dimensions were, but they nodded anyway.

"They entered the realms of the gods," Kuta said. "They told us so. And they saw the gods wage war against each other as their carriages clashed."

That was… not quite what had happened. But not entirely wrong, either. "Something like that," Jack said. "It was complicated."

"Divine matters are always such," Kuta said. "Incomprehensible to mortal minds."

"I wouldn't say that," Daniel objected. "Apophis wanted to conquer the dimension - the realm - and he was defeated and slain by its defenders who wanted to protect everyone from him."

"Pretty straightforward," Jack agreed.

"And the ruler of the realm returned to this realm," Kuta went on. "To reunite with her family. As the goddess has reunited our families, she reunited hers. Praise to the divine She-Ra!"

"Praise to the divine She-Ra!"

Jack winced. They needed better opsec on such missions. Just because those people had been raised as slaves of the Goa'uld didn't make them stupid, he reminded himself. Obviously, the freed former slaves had picked up more about the mission's background than Jack and the others had realised. Or wanted them to. This complicated matters.

And that more people were treating Adora as a goddess wasn't helping, either, but Jack was kind of used to that by now. It was Adora's problem, anyway.

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PU-9623 Orbit, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“This planet doesn't have a Stargate - Apophis didn't want to risk someone else finding it by accident - so we have to take a spaceship to the closest system with a Stargate,” Adora said as their shuttle closed with the Horde frigate in front of them.

“You've explained that already,” Angella replied.

Adora pressed her lips together. Yes, she had done that. But the way Angella stared at the frigate, ignoring everything else around her, and the way she had tensed up when she had seen the shuttle itself, it had seemed as a good way to distract her. At least to Adora. They hadn't thought that Angella didn't have good memories of First Ones shuttles. Or First Ones bases. Or First Ones anything.

No, that was unfair - Adora was a First One, and Angella didn’t have a problem with that. Or hadn't had a problem with it. Maybe that had changed after her ordeal. Or after she had realised that the portal that had almost destroyed Etheria had been based on Beta's research. Angella hadn't said anything, and she had been more distant than before to everyone, even Glimmer, but Adora couldn't help wondering.

In any case, staying here wasn't helping. Angella wouldn't feel comfortable, much less happy, here, not with Micah on Etheria and Beta's presence bringing up so many bad memories.

“Shuttle D-One requesting permission to land,” Bow spoke up from the pilot's seat.

“Permission granted,” a Clone's voice answered through the comm, and the frigate's hangar opened up. “We are at Her Divine Highness's command!”

Adora winced.

“So it is true,” Angella commented. “Hordak's people revere you as a goddess.”

“Not all of them! Only a part,” Adora defended herself.

“Technically, Hordak's people don't,” Catra cut in with a smirk. “Most of his followers are in First Fleet. It's Third Fleet that's full of her worshippers. Though they proselytise.”

Angella frowned but otherwise didn't acknowledge the comment.

“They don't listen to me when I tell them that I am not a goddess,” Adora said.

“How can they claim to follow you if they do not heed your command?” Angella asked.

“Earth people do that all the time,” Catra said, stretching in her seat as the shuttle entered the frigate. “They claim to follow a religion but only follow the rules that they want to follow anyway. However, to be fair, their gods don't talk to their worshippers. Or do anything. Or appear anywhere. So, it's easy for Earth people to claim anything they want about their gods.”

“Priest and his people do obey me,” Adora said, pouting a bit. “They're just… stubborn about their belief in me. And it's not as if I can forbid them from believing in me.”

“Why not?” Angella asked. “They lay claim to you and you don't want it.”

“That would violate their freedom of religion,” Adora explained. “It's an Earth concept,” she added. “We cannot force people to believe or not believe in a religion.”

“What about your freedom not to be worshipped?”

“Ah…” Adora grimaced. “It's complicated.”

“Besides, it's better if they worship Adora than any other god,” Catra said. “If they decided to worship Horde Prime again, or picked someone else who would abuse the power such worship granted them…” She shook her head.

“Like a Goa'uld?” Angella asked.

“That would be very bad,” Adora said, shuddering a little.

“Or any religion on Earth,” Catra added. “Earth's history is full of atrocities committed in the name of their religions - long after they had expelled the Goa'uld who had either founded or taken over most of them.”

The shuttle set down, and Bow started to turn the systems off.

“If you consider them atrocities, I assume they were worse than anything that happened on Etheria,” Angella said as they rose from their seats.

Adora saw Catra flinch at that, and she clenched her teeth.

“Mom!” Glimmer, who had been quiet so far, hissed.

Angella cocked her head and looked at her without saying anything.

Catra shrugged as she didn't care, but Adora knew she was putting on an act. “As far as I know, yes. Though I don't know what you princesses did when you established your kingdoms, back in the day.”

“The history records are a bit spotty,” Bow said with a slightly forced smile as they walked to the back of the shuttle. “And Dad always says that the documents we do have were written by people with a hefty interest in legitimising their actions to strengthen their rule.”

Angella snorted at that. “Indeed. Our history was not quite as noble as many of your peers proclaim. Though given our creators, that shouldn't come as a surprise, even if many of us tried to be better than them.”

Adora pressed her lips together. The First Ones had been planning to sacrifice Etheria to destroy Horde Prime. She wasn't responsible

for that - she had stopped it - but they were her people. Had been her people.

But they had reached the aft of the ship, and Adora saw that the clones were waiting for them, lined up on each side in neat rows. Someone had even laid down a red carpet, perfectly aligned with the ramp.

Angella didn't comment, but Adora couldn't help blushing when the other woman glanced at her.

“I didn't ask for this,” she muttered as they descended the ramp.

But she still smiled when the ship’s captain bowed to her. She might not like being worshipped, but she wouldn't be rude to the clones. They had been raised, created, to be unquestionably loyal by Horde Prime and were still learning how to be free. So, she wouldn't hurt their feelings.

“Your Divine Highness, my ship is at your command! It's an honour to serve you and your companions! Whatever your orders, we will lay down our lives to obey!”

Even if it was hard at times.

*****

Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“So… Here is the latest data from our transdimensional sensors!”

Samantha Carter nodded at Entrapta as she skimmed over the readings.

“Still no conclusive results concerning the dimension’s stability,” Entrapta went on.

“It’s only been a few hours,” Sam replied. “We can’t expect to detect significant changes so soon.”

“It was theoretically possible,” Hordak disagreed. “If we detected solid signs of the dimension destabilising at this point, it would have facilitated matters, of course.”

Sam frowned at him. That was a very cold view.

“But that would have meant that the entire world Angella had created would be fading - including the people!” Entrapta protested.

“Yes.” Hordak nodded. “But if it turns out to be stable, the Alliance will have to deal with it and all the ethical questions that will cause. Given the nature of the world Queen Angella created, that could be a distraction we might not be able to afford in the middle of the war.”

Those were a bit too many ‘might’ and ‘could’ for Sam’s taste, even if Hordak was likely correct. It was one thing to be able to reach a parallel universe, it was another to be able to reach a copy of your world and yourself created by one of your own in another dimension. Sam wasn’t an expert on Etheria’s politics, but she knew enough to know that the princesses wouldn’t just shrug off such a development - certainly not the ones in the Alliance. And if Princess Sweet Bee and her allies heard about Angella having copied them - Sam was pretty sure Angella had done that - then things were bound to turn very complicated.

Entrapta was frowning at Hordak. “Just because something is difficult to handle doesn’t mean we should wish for it to disappear!”

“I am not wishing that the second Etheria disappears; I am merely stating that if it did, it would remove potential problems.” Hordak sounded more than a little defensive. “In fact, the dimension provides us with a host of interesting data. Losing that would be a blow to several avenues of research.”

“Right!” Entrapta smiled again, and Sam suppressed a sigh.

At least, her dealing with the other dimension - she wasn't calling it the funhouse mirror dimension, which was the General's latest proposal - would be limited to the scientific and technical aspects; others would deal with the politics and ethics of it.

And that suited her just fine. Sam was a scientist, not a philosopher or politician.

*****

Gate Area, Near Bright Moon, Etheria, February 5th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Angella had weathered her first trip through the Stargate better than most, Catra noted when they walked down the ramp. She wouldn't have expected that, especially after Angella's experience with the portal that had sent her into her exile. Then again, Angella had kept Bright Moon going during the war against the Horde even after all the first Princess Alliance had fallen apart, so the queen - or former queen; they still hadn't settled that - was tougher than most assumed when they compared her to Glimmer.

Angella looked around, frowning as she took the sight in. "It looks like a Horde base."

"We used their expertise to build the base," Glimmer told her.

"And their style." Angella pressed her lips together.

Catra almost quipped about picking the best people for the job but managed to hold her tongue. This wasn't the time to needle Angella.

"Well… it works well?" Adora smiled weakly. "The Horde prefab elements allow for quick construction and can be customised to many tasks. If was the fastest way to secure the Stargate location."

"It also means that the first thing visitors see of Etheria is a Horde base," Angella retorted.

Catra smirked at that, but Glimmer nodded. “That was actually a point in its favour - no single kingdom can claim precedence this way.”

She was leaving out that the Scorpion Kingdom still heavily used Horde structures, Catra knew, but it seemed to mollify Angella - she was frowning slightly less.

“I guess hosting the Stargate in a base built by Bright Moon might have led to grumblings from other kingdoms,” Angella said as they passed through the scanners.

“Oh, yes!” Glimmer sighed. “Some of them would have never shut up!”

Angella snorted and started to say something in return, but the door opened, and she trailed off, gasping softly at the man standing there. “Micah.”

“Angella.”

Angella started to walk towards him, first slowly, hesitatingly. But suddenly, she rushed forward, faster than Catra had ever seen her moving, all but jumping into Micah’s arms.

Yeah, that explained where Glimmer got it from.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, February 5th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“So. Now that things have settled down, let's talk about politics.”

That’s a nice, bland way to talk about Micah's and Angella's emotional reunion, Catra thought as she leaned back in her seat in the private meeting room. Although she couldn't help contrasting it with Angella's reunion with Glimmer. Granted, that had been under very stressful circumstances, and Angella had thought for years that Micah had been killed by the Horde, but

seeing this - the two were still sitting together very closely, and glancing at each other far more than at anyone else - had to sting Glimmer more than a bit. If someone had done this to Catra… Well, Shadow Weaver would have done this in a heartbeat.

She clenched her teeth. Yeah, she wouldn't want to be in Glimmer's place. But she would ask Angella after this - sometime after this - why Shadow Weaver had been still alive in the other dimension.

“Yes,” Micah said after a moment, nodding and smiling widely at Glimmer.

Angella nodded. “There are several questions to be discussed. And the most important one still needs an answer.” She inclined her head at Glimmer.

Glimmer pressed her lips together in response, and from her angle, Catra saw Bow place his hand on hers under the table. Yeah, the tension between the two queens hadn't improved at all since their return.

But Glimmer controlled her temper - mostly. “You want to know whether I want to stay queen,” she said in a slightly clipped tone.

“Yes.” Angella nodded. “We cannot discuss how to handle this without knowing what you want, Glimmer.”

“No pressure,” Catra muttered under her breath. Only Adora heard her, though - she glanced at Catra with a slight frown.

Glimmer frowned as well. “Shouldn't we focus on what's best for Bright Moon and the Alliance?” she asked, raising her chin.

“You're the current Queen of Bright Moon,” Angella replied. “Forcing you to serve against your will would be as detrimental to either cause as trying to oust you against your will.”

Putting Angella back in charge would definitely be worse, in Catra's opinion. Even if the woman was stable - Catra wasn't sure

about that - how she handled the Horde in the world she had made showed that she shouldn't be ruling Bright Moon or anyone else right now. The inevitable conflict with Adora, the meddling by Earth and Etherian rulers trying to exploit that… No, that wouldn't be a good thing. But Catra saying so, at this point, would likely not be productive.

"I wouldn't be so petty as to sabotage our efforts just because I didn't get my way!" Glimmer protested. "I didn't do so during the Horde War, either!"

"You did not," Angella agreed - although after hesitating a moment. "And yet, there was a lot of friction caused by our differences, friction which hampered the Alliance's efforts."

"Is that why you created my copy to be so obedient?" Glimmer blurted out. She drew back right afterwards, looking almost as if she were surprised at herself, but Angella flinched as if she had been struck.

"I believe every parent wishes at some point that their children would follow their advice," Angella said with a very bland expression.

"I don't think they want mindless bots that follow orders to the letters," Glimmer spat.

Catra pressed her lips together and glanced at Adora. Her love was biting her lower lip and looking from Glimmer to Angella and back. And Bow was useless as well.

Damn. It looked like Catra had to step in between the two queens. She'd rather charge through a minefield. But needs must, and…

Micah spoke up before she could think of the best way to intervene. "When I was on Beast Island, I was… all alone." He wasn't looking at anyone in the room, Catra noted. "There were no other prisoners on the island I could have talked to. Only monsters that wanted to kill me. And the island itself." He took a

deep breath. “I had to struggle to survive. Other prisoners arrived after me, but not many, and none of them lived long enough for me to meet them - I only found their remains. After a while, I don't know how long it took, I stopped looking for them. Or for anyone.” He sighed. “I only had my memories - and I could really trust them either. I don’t know what I would have done if I had had the opportunity to change things.” Now he looked at Glimmer and then Angella. “I wasn't myself.”

Angella slowly nodded, reaching out to hold his hand.

And Glimmer was still pressing her lips together, but she looked less angry.

Then Angella started talking. “I expected to die when I stepped through the portal. I hoped to die since the alternative was… being doomed to be lost forever. And I thought of you.” She glanced at Glimmer, then turned away. “And then I found myself in a void. Floating in nothing. The fate I had feared the most. I don't remember how long it took for things to change - but I know the first things changed, appeared, without me realising I was doing it. Flowers and grass, a patch to sit down. For some time, I thought I was seeing things - that I had gone mad. And I… didn't mind so much. It was better than just floating in the void.” She snorted but without any humour. It sounded more like a sob. “I was a coward. I chose to live in a dream rather than face reality. And in a dream, there are no consequences. Why not indulge yourself? So I did.” She was staring at the desk in front of her. “I could have everything I wanted. My kingdom. My friends. My daughter. My revenge. As long as I was fooling myself.” Another almost-sob. “I knew - thought - that Micah was dead, but in a few years, maybe I would have fooled myself that I had only dreamt his death.”

That was far too personal for Catra. This should have been between Glimmer, Angella and Micah. Catra wasn't part of their family. And she didn't want to be reminded of her own attempt to fool herself into having a perfect world. Her failures. Her crimes. Her…

Adora’s hand squeezing her thigh made her look up. Her love shook her head.

With a wry grin, Catra slowly nodded.

“Mom…” Glimmer's voice cut through the sudden silence. A sob followed. “I didn't… I didn't think.” She sobbed once. “Sorry!”

“I should be sorry,” Angella replied. “I made so many mistakes, even after I realised you had found me.”

“I should have known that. After the war, after Dad had returned…” Glimmer shook her head. “I'm sorry.”

Catra clenched her teeth and grabbed Adora's hand. She really wanted to be anywhere else. Especially when Glimmer and Angella got up and hugged each other, and Adora, Bow and Micah beamed at them.

*****

The Double Cross Part 1

Alliance Base 'Gateway', PU-9623, February 5th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We can't keep the refugees here," Lieutenant Colonel Barnet said as he pointed at the map projected behind him. "This planet is bound to become a battleground as soon as Apophis realises that we have taken it."

Jack O'Neill nodded in agreement, leaning back in his seat. Technically, he was merely an observer at the staff meeting. As of 08:00 today, Barnet was the base commander. His troops, a battalion from the British Army with a fancy name Jack didn't care about very much, had formally relieved Jack's own forces and taken over the base.

But Jack was a general and, with Adora and Glimmer both gone back home to Etheria, he was both the highest-ranking Alliance officer on the planet and the one left in charge of the over-all mission. Which meant dealing with the aftermath of their invasion was his task.

Not that Jack did care too much about formalities. Well, less than the stuffy Brits did.

"General orders prohibit removing native people from their homes unless there's a clear military necessity," Major Smith-Barnesby, Barnet's second-in-command, cut in.

"I don't think the former slaves fall under the definition of 'natives'. They were forcefully moved here to build the base by Apophis," another officer, Captain Thorne, piped up. The guy was a bit young for his rank, in Jack's opinion. Then again, a lot of the officers in the British Army were; they had been expanding their forces by quite a bit gearing up for the war. That kind of build-up put a strain on the officer corps. Last Jack had heard, they were asking retired officers to return.

“I would concur, but that’s not something we can decide,” Smith-Barnesby replied. “However, when it comes to judging the situation here from a military aspect…”

Jack realised that everyone was looking at him. He refrained from sighing too loudly. “Those people were picked for their loyalty to Apophis.” At least, they had been faithful enough to recreate their god even after his queen had used them as test subjects for her experiments. That took a lot of loyalty. Or fear. “So, we can’t exactly trust them, and they represent a potential threat to our forces should Apophis attack this planet.” A very theoretical threat - a bunch of former slaves in a refugee camp didn’t have a prayer of actually threatening, much less damaging the base. “So, we’ll move them off-planet to a safe location.” One someone else could pick.

“That will require another frigate as transport,” Smith-Barnesby pointed out. “That would reduce our naval forces.”

“Not for long,” Jack retorted. And they had handled the entire guard fleet here easily. Missing out on two or three frigates for a day or two wouldn’t make much of a difference.

Everyone nodded at that.

“So, check with our friends in the Navy and get the refugees off this planet. We don’t know when Apophis will counter-attack,” Jack went on. It was too bad that the planet didn’t have a Stargate; with that, it would have made a great staging area or forward base.

“Yes, sir.”

Jack nodded and leaned back again. Not too much - couldn’t rile up the limeys too much.

“Now, the next item to discuss is the supply situation,” Barnet went on. “We have enough food and ammunition for an extended period of combat, but we don’t have spare parts for the more exotic machinery in use here.”

"You mean the research base," Jack said.

"Yes, sir."

"They've got that covered." Between Carter, Entrapta and Hordak, they could probably rebuild the entire research base from scrap.

"Yes, sir." Barnet nodded and made a check on his list. He was probably just covering his ass anyway, in case someone wanted to blame him for any trouble in the research base. That kind of stuff wouldn't fly under Jack or any of his people, but it was common enough in the army.

"Next item. The mess hall. There have been complaints about the menu selection."

Jack sighed under his breath and refrained from commenting about offering the complainers to eat MREs instead. As soon as the fighting was over, the tedious paperwork began.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, February 5th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Whew! Glad that's over!"

Adora frowned at Catra's outburst and checked that the door behind them was closed. If Glimmer, Angella and Micah had heard that… "It's great to see them doing so well," she said.

"They still have to sort out politics," Catra said, stretching her arms over her head and craning her neck. "Glimmer's got to man up and tell Angella that she'll stay queen."

"You think she should stay queen?" Bow asked.

"You don't?" Catra shot back, raising her eyebrows.

"It's her decision," Bow replied. "And she hasn't made up her mind yet. So much happened since we found Angella…"

"What's there to make up her mind about?" Catra snorted. "You have met Angella. Do you think she could be the queen Bright Moon needs right now?"

"Well… we haven't really talked to her that much about that," Bow said.

Catra rolled her eyes and then looked at Adora.

Adora coughed. She didn't like to be put on the spot like this. Glimmer was her best friend, and Angella was… Angella had welcomed her into the Alliance despite her origin. And Angella had sacrificed herself so Adora hadn't done it. "We met Angella under very special circumstances. We can't judge her for that."

"What circumstances? An attack by Apophis?" Catra scoffed. "We're at war with the Goa'uld. Angella doesn't know anything about them. And she doesn't know anything about Earth. Even if she hadn't been isolated for years, she would have trouble adjusting to the current situation."

That wasn't wrong. And yet… "It's Glimmer's choice," Adora said. She wouldn't stab her friend in the back.

Catra narrowed her eyes, then snorted again. "Then let's hope that she makes the right decision."

*****

"So… Mom and Dad have 'retired for the evening'. They've got a lot to talk about. And stuff."

Adora nodded at Glimmer's comment. They had a lot to talk about, indeed. They hadn't seen each other for so long - almost twenty years. Well, closer to twenty than to ten, at least. They must be very… She felt her cheeks grow warm.

"Yes, *that*." Glimmer rolled her eyes before she sighed and sat down on the couch in Adora's room, next to Bow.

Adora glanced at Catra, expecting a comment, but her lover just nodded and curled up a bit more on the armrest of Adora's seat. Turning back to Glimmer, Adora nodded again. What should she say about that? It was natural, after all. Perfectly fine. She'd do the same if she had been separated from Catra for so long. She had done the same after they had returned to Bright Moon today.

She felt her cheeks heat up again, and Catra snorted.

"Anyway," Glimmer continued. "That's not a problem."

"Of course not," Catra muttered under her breath.

"The problem is the succession question." Glimmer shook her head. "Mom said it's my choice. Well, she said what I want is the most important thing about it. But not everyone thinks so."

"Oh?" Adora frowned. "It's an internal matter of Bright Moon, isn't it?" Other kingdoms didn't meddle with each other's internal matters. Especially not with each other's royal family matters. That was a fundamental principle since the Princess Prom had started.

"Yes!" Glimmer blurted out with a frown.

"But?" Adora leaned a bit forward, and Catra slipped an arm around her shoulders from behind and the side.

Bow cleared his throat. "Well… it's a basic principle of Etherian politics and diplomacy not to interfere with questions of succession. But every rule has exceptions."

"And the first rule is: Don't get caught," Catra added with another snort.

"Did any other Alliance member else actually… try to interfere?" Adora couldn't imagine any of their friends trying to meddle in this

matter.

"They only sent their well-wishes," Bow said after a glance at Glimmer. "But they also stated their intention to come by as soon as Angella was up to receiving visitors."

Well, that was only natural - all of the other princesses knew Angella well. Some of them had known her much longer than Adora.

"And once they arrive, they'll want to know if they're visiting the former or current Queen of Bright Moon," Glimmer added with a scowl.

"And if you wait too long, they'll suspect that there's trouble," Catra said. "And Sweet Bee will spread rumours that you've got Angella locked up in a dungeon because she disagrees with your policies."

Adora gasped. Her lover couldn't be serious, could she?

"Something like that," Glimmer grumbled. "And even if we can handle the other kingdoms, there's still Bright Moon itself. The servants already call Mom 'Queen'."

Adora blinked. "Ah… That's kind of… they don't want to presume?" she guessed.

"Some slipped and called me *Princess*." Glimmer was scowling now.

"That's a presumption, yes," Catra said. With her lover pressed into her side now, Adora felt her nod. "Though… what do you call *former* Queens?"

"Generally, former rulers are called by their last title," Bow said. "Though since for everyone else that's generally 'Princess', it's not really helpful." He smiled weakly. "Bright Moon is unique in that the title of our ruling princess is 'Queen' and not 'Princess'."

"Something Mom set up," Glimmer said. "And since she founded the kingdom, there hasn't been another queen so far, so there's no precedent. And everyone's used to her being queen, anyway."

Adora could see the problem. But she could also see the solution. "So, it's up to Angella to set a precedent, then."

Glimmer frowned at her as if she had said something wrong.

"Both Glimmer and Angella have to set the precedent," Bow said.

Ah! Adora grimaced at her faux-pas.

"Yes. And Mom says it depends on what I want." Glimmer pouted again.

"So, what do you want?" Catra asked. That earned her a glare from Glimmer, which she shrugged off. "It is your decision," she added, echoing Adora's earlier words.

"Yes." Glimmer sighed and leaned back on the couch, looking at the ceiling. "I want to stay Queen."

Adora started to nod. That was settled…

"But I don't know if I want to stay queen with Mom looking over my shoulder," Glimmer went on. "Watching me make mistakes, criticising me…"

"I don't think she'll do that," Bow said.

"If she didn't say anything, it would be even worse!" Glimmer spat. "Imagine her silently judging me!"

"Ah…" Bow grimaced. "But you've been a good queen! You've ruled Bright Moon fairly and well."

"I was the only queen," Glimmer said. "It's not as if there was anyone else to take over. Dad's the king, but only because he

married Mom. He’s not in the royal line. So, it’s not as if there was any alternative.”

Oh. Adora could see her point, but this was far too pessimistic. Or paranoid, Catra would say. “But you are a good queen,” she said. “You handled the Alliance - both Alliances - and the Stargate well. And you’ve been running the Princess Alliance in the war.”

“And without making any blunders,” Catra added.

Glimmer looked surprised, then sighed again. “But who’s to say I couldn’t have done better? Mom’s got much more experience!”

“But not with the war against the Goa’uld - or with other planets,” Catra said.

Adora nodded with an encouraging smile. “And Angella knows that. Or will know it once Micah tells her.”

Bow nodded as well. “Yes. If Angella didn’t trust you, she wouldn’t have said that what you want matters most.”

Glimmer slowly nodded, but she didn’t seem convinced. Adora could tell.

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Research Station Beta, PU-9623, February 6th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Due to its special nature, conducting experiments in the target dimension requires sapient test subjects or researchers. Therefore, until such are available - volunteers, of course - I suggest switching the research focus of this base to another dimension.”

Samantha Carter narrowed her eyes at Beta. The bot’s 'volunteers, of course’ sounded like an afterthought at best - more like a formality. Sam had no doubt that Beta only said it because she was aware that the Alliance wasn't like the Goa'uld and

wouldn't tolerate using humans as test subjects. On the other hand, Beta was correct that all transdimensional research currently planned was limited to observing the target dimension.

Behind her, she heard Entrapta gasp. “Oh, no! We forgot about how Angella returning would affect you and your research! We're so sorry!”

Sam wasn't sorry. While she could understand very well how it felt when your research project fell victim to a change of policy or budgeting, Beta had, and eagerly, Sam was sure, been sending people as test subjects to another dimension - one dangerous and unstable - against their will. That was unacceptable, and as Alpha's example showed, this blatant lack of ethics couldn't be blamed on the Goa'uld. She didn't say so, though - at least, Beta had abandoned Taweret when Adora and the General had arrived. As long as Beta didn't attempt to sway Entrapta to her way of thinking, Sam could keep her thoughts private.

“What dimension do you suggest?” Hordak asked. He sounded interested. Of course, he had pursued interdimensional travel for decades, but that had been back when he had desperately tried to return to Horde Prime's side. But maybe he still held some passion for the subject? More than he held for the research into stabilising and reversing the genetic degradation of the Asgard, which Loki was pushing back at Alpha?

Beta nodded at him. “The target dimension was always meant to be a transitional target, a step between our dimension and the actual goal of the research done here - *Ascension*.” Sam could hear the capital letters. “So, it would only be logical to switch the focus from exploring the target dimension to directly looking for the dimension inhabitated by those who have ascended.”

Sam pressed her lips together. She hadn't explored that specific area very thoroughly, but she had studied the material available and what she had found… “As far as I know, travelling to that dimension is irreversible. And that includes scans” At least, all the Ancients’ data agreed on that - they had only indirect data about

the dimension, extrapolated from examining adjacent or related dimensions, models, and what scans could be taken when an Ancient had ascended. And claims from Ancients before their ascensions, which were obviously of dubious veracity.

“Oh!” Entrapata beamed. “That sounds fascinating! Almost like trying to visit gods!”

“Gods?” Beta cocked her head to the side in an almost human gesture. “Like Adora?”

“Oh, not like her!” Entrapta shook her head. “I mean the kind of gods worshipped on Earth that are intangible, invisible and cannot be perceived or contacted by any means that would result in factual data.”

Beta nodded. “That would describe an ascended being somewhat adequately if one lacked actual data.”

“It would also fit a fictional being,” Hordak commented in a dry voice. “Though most proponents of the Earth religions based on these kinds of gods insist that their deity of choice is able to both physically and mentally affect them despite a profound lack of evidence for such.”

“That doesn't sound very scientific,” Beta commented. “Although this might be based on past tales of Ascension and, therefore, might be of historical if not scientific interest.”

Sam shook her head. “I think we should focus on more practical research.” Instead of poking that particular can of worms. The last thing the Alliance or anyone needed was Beta trying to examine religion. Not that trying to reach a dimension populated by the kind of ascended beings Beta described was much better. Sam couldn't help thinking of ancient myths about mortals visiting Olympos. That kind of venture rarely ended well for the mortals.

“Of course,” Beta agreed. “We cannot squander our means.”

“If we're talking about practical aspects of research into transdimensional travel, I would suggest renewed research into using other dimensions as a way to travel faster than our current methods,” Hordak said. “If we succeed, our fleet would benefit from unparalleled strategic mobility.”

“Oh, yes! We could use other dimensions as shortcuts!” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically.

Sam nodded as well. If they could move fleets around much faster than with their current methods, the greater numbers of ships fielded by the Goa’uld Empire would become all but irrelevant since the Alliance could concentrate the bulk of their forces and strike faster than the Goa'uld could react.

“I see the potential applications.” Beta didn't seem very enthusiastic about it, Sam noted. “Although…” She suddenly trailed off. “We've received a message from the former commander's ally, Apophis. It is addressed at Taweret.”

Sam drew a sharp breath through clenched teeth. “What does it say?”

“As far as I understand it, it's a request for a meeting over faster-than-light communicators.” Beta played the message.

A demand, actually, Sam thought. Just more politely worded since Taweret was - had been - Apophis's queen. And while they could stall a bit, Apophis would likely know that a dimensional experiment would render communication impossible for its duration, they would be expected to answer before long.

Beta cocked her head to the side again. “Commander O’Neill has called for an immediate meeting.”

As expected.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, February 6th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We really need to collect a few Stargates to mount on frigates," Catra commented as she sat down in her usual seat in the meeting room. "This would be so much easier if we had a mobile gate in the PU-whatever-system. And we need a better name for the system as well. Who exactly is in charge of that?"

"The Stargates, or the naming?" Adora asked as she joined her, almost sitting down before standing again. "Bow, do you need any help?"

"No, thanks, Adora," he replied. "Just running a last check on the projector and communicator array here before the meeting starts."

"We don't want a technical problem to delay this." Glimmer must have caught the last part when she entered the room.

Catra cocked her head. Her ears twitched, but she didn't hear any more steps from the hallway.

Glimmer rolled her eyes. "Mom and Dad aren't coming."

"Oh?" Adora blinked.

"This is an Alliance matter," Glimmer said. "And they aren't up to date about our military situation."

"Ah."

Catra wasn't so sure about Micah being out of the loop - that didn't sound like him - but he was probably focused on Angella. And Angella *definitely* was out of the loop. The last time she had been on Etheria, the world had still been stuck in Despondos, and the most advanced military technology on it had been Horde Bots and Hovertanks. Another reason why Glimmer should stay queen.

"We're ready!" Bow announced as he got up and walked over to his seat.

“And just in time!” Adora smiled.

“Connecting,” Bow announced, pushing a few buttons on his tablet.

Catra’s ears twitched again as the projector started to hum, and several screens appeared around the table, lighting up one after the other and showing the rest of the participants. Jack, Sam, Entrapta, Hordak, Daniel, Sha're, Teal'c. And Beta appeared inside the room as a holoprojection.

On the screen in the centre, Jack's eyes darted around for a moment, then settled on what must be the camera facing him in his meeting room. *“So… you've heard the news? Apophis is making a booty call.”*

“Jack!” Daniel protested.

“He wants to talk to Taweret. You know what the king and queen get up to,” Jack replied.

Catra chuckled at that - and even more when she saw Glimmer’s grimace.

“Jack!” Daniel looked aghast.

“General!” And Sam looked annoyed.

“Sorry.” Jack didn’t seem to be sorry. *“Anyway, Apophis called half an hour ago, demanding to talk to Taweret. We've got about an hour to decide how to handle that - that's how long an experiment usually blocks communications according to Beta.”*

The bot's projection nodded. *“Past records show that this is roughly the time passing before Apophis will resend his message.”*

“And we can't get Taweret to answer it - the snake's already with the Tok'ra to get separated from her host,” Jack went on.

“Can we fake such a call?” Glimmer asked.

"Technically, yes," Entrapta replied. *"At least for the appearance on a screen. We have to tweak the records we made, but that's just data."*

"However, faking her speech patterns for a call…" Sam winced. *"That's a bigger challenge. We don't have enough records of her talking, and most of them are from when she was already a prisoner. Apophis likely will see through such a ruse."*

"Even Double Trouble would have problems impersonating Taweret convincingly under such conditions," Bow added, nodding. "Not that we would consider that," he hastily added.

Double Trouble would be as likely to join the Goa'uld as to stick to the script if only to cause more chaos, Catra thought with a scowl. And the question would not be whether but when they'd betray the Alliance.

"Of course not," Glimmer agreed with a scoff.

"So, fooling Apophis into thinking all's going according to plan is out," Jack said.

"It would only have been a temporary solution anyway," Sha're added. *"He would check with his commander and his spies in the guard fleet afterwards even if he were fooled."*

"So… do we call him out and taunt him about having taken another queen of his prisoner?" Jack was joking, but Catra had no doubt that he would love to do it.

"That would reveal our Alliance," Adora said with a frown. "And an attempt to pose as a rival System Lord would require more Ha'taks than we have access to. We have to either stall for time and evacuate the entire planet or pose as a Horde task force."

"We have to assume that Apophis knows about Horde Prime's demise," Hordak pointed out. *"So, it would have to be a rogue Horde task force."*

Even a rogue Horde task force would probably be impressive enough to keep Apophis at bay, Catra thought. "Going after their old enemy?" She shrugged. "Could work."

"Why not inform him that the research station has been returned under the control of its original owners?" Beta asked.

Pose as First Ones? Catra blinked, then glanced at Adora. That would mean her love would have to play the part of the First Ones - the kinds who were experimenting with people and willing to sacrifice Etheria to win their war. Catra didn't think that would be good for her. Or that she'd be good at it. But she knew Adora would still try it if she thought it would be the best solution for their problem. Though it wasn't, and not just because Adora was really bad at lying. "We don't have First Ones ships," she pointed out. "And claiming we took over the Horde would probably not sound too convincing. Even if it's actually true," she added with a grin.

"We only have Darla. And a few shuttles," Entrapta added. *"That's not enough for a fleet."*

"So, Plan Horde it is," Jack said.

No one disagreed.

*****

PU-9623 Orbit, February 6th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Open a channel to Apophis using the relay in the base. I will inform him that this system is no longer under his control - or of his concern."

Hordak was better already getting into his act, Jack O'Neill thought as the Horde clones on the bridge complied. Because the tone of the order reminded Jack a bit too much of the snakes. Uncomfortably so, especially in light of what Hordak had done in the past. Sure, he was reformed now, and apparently loyal, but…

Jack had heard that before. Usually from intel weenies about local ‘allies’ on missions that never showed up in any official files. Well, he was keeping his eyes on the guy. Which was why he was here, on the frigate serving as flagship, instead of in the base on the ground. Just in case.

“Communication established.”

Hordak straightened, and Jack checked again that the ‘flag room’ in which he was observing wasn’t visible on the camera feed covering the bridge. Just in case.

Then, the big screen on the bridge changed from showing the planet below them to Apophis. *“Finally! I was…”* He trailed off, mouth half-open for a moment as he stared at Hordak, and Jack had to snort. Carter would have to make him a copy of that picture. He checked the feed from Bright Moon - yeah, the princesses were snickering.

“Apophis, I presume,” Hordak said, seated on the captain's chair on the bridge in full armour.

“You are not Horde Prime,” Apophis spat. He had recovered quickly from his surprise, Jack had to admit.

“I am Hordak. Leader of the Horde. Conqueror of Etheria.”

Apophis wasn't in his throne room, Jack noted, but in his private quarters. Same amount of gold and other bling, but no guards and flunkies lining the walls. *“You're using the communicator in my base.”* And there was a familiar scowl. Snake boy didn't like this at all.

“Your base was protecting an installation of our enemies,” Hordak said. “I took it.”

Apophis tilted his head slightly and his eyes narrowed. Props for self-control. Jack saw him glance to the side, at a screen next to his seat. Probably checking the status of his guard fleet. *“You*

attacked my fleet," he said a moment later, confirming Jack's guess.

"None shall stay in our way to obey Horde Prime's orders," Hordak went on. "Our holy duty shall be done."

And now he was channelling Priest. Jack grimaced,

Apophis frowned for a moment. *"Horde Prime was fighting the descendants of the Gate Builders."*

"We call them the First Ones. Horde Prime vanquished them, but some of them yet remain scattered in their former realm. Hiding amongst the lesser species." Hordak scoffed. "None of them shall escape our wrath, as the one on this planet found out."

Apophis jerked, and on the screen in the flag room, Jack saw his jaw muscles tense as he clenched his teeth. So, he had known that Taweret's host was a descendant of the Ancients. That had been assumed, but confirmation was always good.

Yet the snake didn't rant or threaten after hearing that his queen had been supposedly killed. He merely nodded. *"I was informed that Horde Prime had met his end."*

"Horde Prime is eternal," Hordak replied at once, straightening. "He sees all, knows all, and controls all."

Apophis nodded again, and Jack thought he saw his eyes narrow just a bit more. *"And he tasked you with hunting down his enemies in my realm?"*

"Wherever they are hiding," Hordak said. "None shall escape their fate. Such Horde Prime decreed, such shall happen."

"Such Horde Prime decreed, such shall happen," the clones in the background repeated his words.

Definitely too many Priest vibes for Jack's taste. He glanced to his side and saw that Adora was grimacing on the screen showing

Bright Moon's meeting room. But they were counting on Apophis being more cautious when he thought he wasn't facing a warlord, but a zealot.

"I see." The snake nodded. Then his lips twisted into a faint, nasty smile. *"Are you aware that there is a planet full of descendants of those First Ones?"*

What? Jack drew a short breath. Was Apophis…?

"What is this planet?" Hordak asked.

"It's populated by billions of the lesser species you are already familiar with, with the First Ones hiding amongst them - ruling from the shadows. Building up their forces and technology to use them in war. And I think we both know who they will wage war against."

Oh, that bastard!

Apophis's smile grew wider. *"It's called Earth. I can give you all our data on it."*

*****

Hyperspace, On the Way to PU-9623, February 6th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"He didn't even ask what happened to Taweret." Adora shook her head as she paced in their cabin - the captain had tried to get her to use his cabin, but she had put a stop to that.

"He's a Goa'uld. They don't care about others," Catra said, looking at her upside down - she was sprawled on her back on the bed, head hanging over the edge.

"I know that," Adora replied. "But she was his queen. Without her, he can't supply his Jaffa with symbionts. That will cripple his recruitment if he can't replace her."

“True. But he replaced Amaunet with Taweret,” Catra pointed out.

“I don’t think there are too many Goa’uld queens left who aren’t already attached to a System Lord,” Adora said. At least, the Tok’ra didn’t know of any.

“We thought that back then as well.” Catra snorted. “I’m not holding my breath. He probably has some contingency plans already lined up. Never underestimate your enemy. You saw how quickly he adapted to Hordak’s claims.”

“Yes.” Adora sighed. They had hoped that losing his queen, his base and his forces in the system would unbalance him.

“For what intel he had, it was quite a smart plan he came up with in the middle of the call,” Catra went on. “Set the new enemy on your old enemy and let them fight.”

“No matter who comes out on top, he wins,” Adora agreed.

“And he’ll be waiting and checking if he can mop up the survivors with his forces.” Catra shifted around a bit. “Or ask for a favour if Hordak wins. Like getting Taweret back.”

Adora nodded. “It was weird, though, that he didn’t ask about her,” she repeated herself. “Her host was a First One, not her.” Apophis had to know that the Horde was aware of the Goa’uld and how they took over people.

“He probably didn’t want to mention his close association with an enemy of a religious fanatic in charge of a fleet,” Catra said. “I wouldn’t want to do it either. And he might fear that Taweret threatened Hordak with his retaliation.”

“Maybe.” Adora shrugged and sat down at the desk. “It was a spur-of-the-moment decision. He’ll likely adapt his reaction - or has done so already. He might even ask for a meeting.”

“Would be an ideal opportunity to ambush him,” Catra said.

What? Adora drew a sharp breath. Catra had done exactly this at the Princess Prom! She knew better than that! "We won't break diplomatic conventions and abuse a meeting under truce!"

"It wouldn't be a meeting between the Alliance and Apophis, but one we duped him into," Catra retorted. "We would crash a meeting between Goa'uld System Lords to take them out - even if we had to infiltrate the meeting under a false flag," Catra said. "Didn't you wear Horde uniforms once to infiltrate a base?"

"That's not the same!" Adora shook her head. "We have to draw the line at posing as someone else to lure someone into a diplomatic meeting so we can ambush them. If we do that, no one will trust us - or the clones - any more."

"I'd say it depends on if there are witnesses left afterwards, but I guess some idiot would leak it to the press." Catra shifted and lay on her side, one hand propping up her head. "But I bet you that Jack will propose such an ambush if Apophis wants a meeting."

Adora pressed her lips together. Jack would indeed propose such a plan. Quite passionately. But the Alliance didn't work like that. Morals aside, the diplomatic and political costs would be too high. How could your friends trust you if you used such means? She changed the subject. "Anyway, Apophis will have to be ready to invade Earth. He can't leave either Hordak with Earth's resources or Earth with Hordak's knowledge."

"He'll first have to confirm whether Horde Prime is dead or not," Catra said. "In his current delicate situation, with his rivals ready to pounce him, he can't risk angering Horde Prime by attacking his task forces."

Adora nodded. They had some time. "And we can use this to make it look as if Hordak has taken over Earth." As long as they hid Earth's new ships-

"Yes." Catra nodded, then blinked - and cursed. "I just had a thought. What if he plans a false-flag operation to hit Earth and

hopes that the Horde goes after a rival of his? He probably wouldn't risk it if Horde Prime were still alive, but if he thinks this is just a splinter group…"

"That sounds like something he'd do," Adora agreed. "Or he tries to manipulate a rival to strike."

"If he could do that, I think he'd have done it already to his rivals," Catra said.

"Never underestimate your enemy," Adora quoted her - and grinned at her scowl.

Her mirth didn't last, though. They had to deal with Apophis before things took a turn for the worse. The last thing they wanted was for the Goa'uld to find out the truth about the Alliance and unite in response. And using a fictive Horde remnant to guard Earth in the guise of having conquered it came quite close to revealing that truth.

*****

Alliance Base 'Gateway', PU-9623, February 7th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We really need to get a Stargate here. Apophis wanted to hide the location from his rivals and probably wanted to isolate Taweret so she couldn't easily go and meet others, but neither is a concern for us. And the research station is too important to abandon," Catra said as she took her seat in the meeting room. "And having to spend a day travelling here every time something happens is a waste of time."

Samantha Carter agreed with the proposal. "Yes. We could relocate the base, but it would take a significant effort and spacelift capacity to move and reinstall all the dimensional portal projectors."

"Protecting the system here also requires significant, potentially crucial forces," Captain Thorne pointed out. "And aren't we getting

dedicated Fleet Transports?”

Sam gave the man props for speaking up as the most junior officer at this gathering, but he was wrong. “Due to the nature of the transdimensional experiments, we can't run them on either Earth or Etheria - the effects on advanced technology would be nigh-catastrophic. Not even Etheria's magic or Earth's native technology could mitigate the effects of regular suppression of key pieces of advanced technology.”

Thorne blinked in obvious surprise, but his expression quickly changed to a frown as he defended his idea. “Couldn't you install the lab on some moon?”

“The moon would be too close to Earth,” Entrapta spoke up. “Like any of the moons of Etheria. We could pick another planet, I guess, but Mars has a base already, and we'd interfere with them. Maybe some of the moons of Saturn or Jupiter?”

“Those would require dedicated defences as well,” Sam pointed out. Sure, the task force protecting the Solar System would cover that as well, and could focus on an attack on such a moon, but they couldn't leave Earth unprotected and so were not able to respond with the full force to an attack on the base.

“And we might not want a portal to alternate dimensions or universes that close to a populated planet,” the General pointed out. “Or add more strain to Earth's Stargate. The schedule is crowded already - Hammond is giving me the evil eye whenever I want to take a trip,” he added with a grin.

He was making light of it, but he was correct - between the Alliance’s ever-increasing needs and the United Nations missions, Stargate Command already had to draw up schedules that showed similarities to those used to handle traffic at major train stations or airports.

“But if it’s in another system we'd still have to travel from Earth to it, so wouldn't that actually be a wash for additional gate trips?”

Thorne wasn't giving up. At least he didn't seem to be the type who just couldn't accept a woman's opinion no matter how well-founded since he was arguing against the General as well.

“I think we should discuss this at a later meeting,” Lieutenant Colonel Barnet stepped in, giving Thorpe a look that made the young man wince.

“Yep.” The General nodded. “We're here to discuss Apophis’s attempt to set the Horde against Earth. Did you finish analysing the data he sent to Hordak, Carter?”

Sam straightened. “Yes, sir.” She used her remote to activate the holoprojector in the room. “While the navigational data is correct, as expected, there are significant discrepancies in the data covering Earth's defences compared to Apophis's confirmed knowledge and most of his data covering the supposed influence of Ancients on Earth seems made up.”

“What a surprise!” The General snorted. “Apophis is not being honest? Who would have thought?”

“What kind of discrepancies?” Hordak asked.

“His data claims a scouting force of his fleet was ambushed and destroyed by unknown means,” Sam explained. “He didn't give any details at all about his intrusion.”

“A vague warning?” The General frowned. “Does he want the clones to be paranoid so they shoot first and ask no questions later?”

“Horde doctrine would be to send a small scouting flotilla into a new system,” Hordak said. “Horde Prime generally preferred to use overwhelming force after he was sure about a target's defences.”

“Apophis might not be aware of that,” Adora said.

“Or he just didn't want to tell people about his defeat,” Catra added.

“Well, as far as Apophis knows, we were working on anti-ship missiles, and we've had a few years to develop them further. So he probably hopes we’ll take out a few ships at least,” the General said.

“Prompting retaliation,” Catra added. “And then he sweeps in and destroys the survivors if they seem weakened enough. But can he spare a fleet large enough for that?”

“Intel from the Tok'ra and our own analysis would indicate he can't,” Sam said. “Although as the situation changes, so do priorities.”

“And Apophis suffered another loss. He might be in a tight enough bind to take a riskier gamble,” the General said.

“Indeed.” Teal'c nodded slowly. “The experiments Taweret ran here were an attempt to find a superweapon to win against his enemies. With that spoiled, he must find another way to triumph or risk defeat at the hands of his numerous enemies. Acquiring Horde technology might appear tempting to him.”

“And if he can snatch it from a drifting hull wrecked by us while fighting is still going on…” The General nodded. “And he can probably spare a few cloaked ships much easier than he can spare a fleet able to take out a Horde force.” He frowned. “But it's still a massive gamble. He doesn't know if we successfully upgraded our missiles so they can deal with shields, and he doesn't know what the Horde would do. Desperate or not, that seems a bit too risky for Apophis.”

“He would prefer to operate with more information,” Teal'c said. “But that's not always possible.”

“That's why data is so important!” Entrapta nodded emphatically.

Sam was about to agree when her computer lit up with a priority message. She opened it and gasped. “Adora? Sir?”

“Yes?”

“Carter?”

“Alliance Headquarters just informed me that Stargate Command was contacted by rebel Jaffa through the Stargate. They sent a warning about an impending attack by ‘the Horde’ against Earth.”

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The Double Cross Part 2

Alliance Base 'Gateway', PU-9623, February 7th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Do we know if those 'rebel Jaffa' are actual rebels?" Catra asked after checking the message on her pad. "If Apophis is trying to make the Horde run into a prepared ambush by Earth, this would be an easy way to alert us."

"Well, it's kinda hard. They don't carry badges to prove their identity," Jack replied with a shrug. "And we haven't had contact with many rebel Jaffa."

"Rebels are often isolated. At best, they are organised in cells, but they are slow to trust anyone due to the danger of encountering a spy for the false gods. Bra'tac knew a number of rebels and sympathisers within Apophis's ranks, and even he, a known dissenter, was not trusted by many," Teal'c added. "Unfortunately, a lot of his knowledge died with him."

"He couldn't risk that knowledge falling into the wrong hands should any member of SG-1 become captured and taken over by a Goa'uld," Sha're said. "Apophis discussed your possible capture several times with Amaunet, and finding out if there were other traitors like Teal'c was one of his priorities. He assumed that your successes were at least partly due to such traitors."

"Well, looks like you left a lasting impression on him, Teal'c," Jack said with a grin. "Even though I'm a bit annoyed that he thinks we only kicked his ass thanks to inside help."

"Several of our most important successes were only achieved thanks to Teal'c and Bra'tac's help," Daniel pointed out.

"Yes, yes. But this makes us sound as if we're just spooks," Jack retorted.

“Having the enemy underestimate you is a great boon in war,” Teal’c said. His expression didn’t change from his usual stoic one, but he did sound a little smug to Catra’s ears.

“So, we don’t know if we can trust them,” Adora summed up.

“If we can have Melog meet them, we should be able to find out if they wish us ill,” Catra said. Melog should be able to sense their feelings somewhat, at least. “But even if they’re genuine, they could still be duped by Apophis.”

“While Apophis is fond of executing rebels, it is not beyond him to have spies infiltrate a rebel cell and then use that to root out more potential dissent,” Teal’c said.

“Yeah, standard spook practice. Use the known spies to find their contacts,” Jack said.

Catra nodded. “And you can feed them the information you want the enemy to have. Such as a warning about a coming attack by another enemy of yours.”

“Ensuring that they run into a prepared enemy.” Jack shook his head. “We’ll have to put on a good show back home if we want to fool Apophis.”

“Do the Tok’ra have any information?” Adora asked.

Jack glanced at Sam, who shook her head. “We haven’t received any information from them about this.”

“We’ll ask them to look into this,” Adora said.

Catra narrowed her eyes. “The talk between Apophis and Hordak was a private channel. If rebel Jaffa know about it, they either have tapped his private communications or Apophis shared the news with at least one of them.”

“I do not think any rebel Jaffa have penetrated his communications to that degree,” Teal’c said. “I was his Prime and

did not have such access, and Apophis will have increased security after my defection."

Catra agreed with that. Not even the Tok'ra had managed that, and they had thousands of years of experience infiltrating the Goa'uld. Then again… "They could be lucky," she said. "But I think it's more likely that Apophis deliberately let that information leak."

"If he does, he risks his rival System Lords hearing about it as well," Sha're pointed out. "Although that, too, might be intended if he has plans to set them up as well."

"Send them after the Horde?" Jack snorted. "That would allow us to fight them with our forces while hiding the involvement of the other members of the Alliance."

It would also alert the Goa'uld that the Horde was attacking at least one of them, but they knew that when they started Plan Horde, as Jack called it. "We'll have to make efforts to show that this 'rogue Horde task force' is not going to indiscriminately all Goa'uld, or they might unite."

"Yes!" Adora nodded. "If they think this is between us and Apophis, they might stay out - or stab him in the back."

"Apophis knows that," Sha're said. "He might plan to use the threat of the Horde as a way to force the other System Lords into a truce and alliance against them. It would give him breathing room to consolidate and restore his forces while his rivals suffer losses."

"Every one of the false gods will attempt to use such a war to weaken their rivals," Teal'c said. "However, they are all aware of this and will plan accordingly. Overall, it will diminish the effectiveness of their forces, but we cannot count on them fracturing in a suicidal manner in the face of a common enemy."

"The System Lords aren't stupid," Daniel said. "They are used to each other." He took a deep breath, then bit his lower lip for a

moment. “We might consider diplomatic approaches to prevent them from seeing us as a threat to all of them.”

“Sounds good,” Jack said with a grin. “If we can divide them, we can mop up the rest more easily.”

Catra agreed but winced slightly. It was a good plan, but…

“We can’t do that!” Adora blurted out.

…Adora wouldn’t like it.

*****

“Why can’t we do that? It’s a legitimate ruse of war.” Jack O’Neill frowned. Fooling your enemy any way you could was a basic principle of warfare.

“You don’t abuse diplomatic customs like that,” Adora retorted. “Who could trust our word if we break it like that?”

“There’s a difference between breaking your word or treaty and posing as someone else to fool your enemy,” Jack pointed out. “That’s like spying on your enemy or feeding them bad intel.”

Catra nodded in agreement, Jack saw, but her expression looked a bit too resigned for his taste.

“It would not be dishonourable. Technically,” Teal’c added, though his expression didn’t make it clear if he approved or not.

“That’s not the same. If we make a treaty under false pretences to entrap our enemies, it might be technically different, but it still casts doubt on all our treaties,” Adora said. “Other people will always wonder if we’re about to betray them as well.”

Jack snorted. “We’re talking about the Goa’uld. Anyone who’s ever met them knows they aren’t trustworthy and will betray you as soon as they think they can get away with it.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “But we’re not the Goa’uld. What will the Asgard think? Or the Tok’ra?”

“The Asgard have made a treaty with the Goa’uld as well, Jack,” Daniel butted in.

“And they know the Goa’uld would break it if they could or knew they could. They didn’t build a snake maze on Cimmeria because they trusted them,” Jack said. “And the Tok’ra are all about underhanded spy stuff.”

“I’m not saying we should trust the Goa’uld. But we have to maintain a higher standard,” Adora insisted with a frown. “We don’t want a reputation for such treachery when we deal with other species. We want others to trust us.”

“We also don’t want to lose the war,” Jack said.

“We won’t lose the war if we respect the customs and the spirit of diplomacy,” Adora said.

“But it could prolong the war and cause more casualties,” Jack countered.

He saw Adora flinch at that. But a moment later, she shook her head and raised her chin. “In the long term, we lose even more if people don’t trust us. If they expect us to stab them in the back, they’ll react accordingly if there’s a conflict - or a misunderstanding.”

And that made Catra flinch.

“I have to agree,” Daniel said, stabbing Jack in the back. “It’s not just an undercover operation scaled up if you actually make a treaty under false pretences. That would be seen as dishonourable by many cultures.” Jack frowned at him, but he shrugged. “It might be a double standard, and only gets applied if someone gets caught, but you can’t ignore that such, ah, ploys tend to undermine your reputation as well as weaken the general trust in diplomacy.”

Jack scowled. That made some sense, but it still felt like voluntarily hobbling yourself. It wasn't a war crime like murdering prisoners of war or civilians - which made things worse, anyway - but it would make it easier to defeat the snakes with the least number of losses.

He glanced at the others in the room. Daniel clearly thought Adora was correct. Catra seemed to disagree, or at least have some doubts, but she clearly wouldn't go against Adora's wishes either. Teal'c's expression was unreadable, and Sha're hadn't said anything yet so her scowling could be aimed at anyone. Both wanted the snakes to be crushed, of course, but Teal'c prized honour, and while Sha're wouldn't blindly follow Daniel, she might weigh the political cost of such a deception as more important than the military advantages it might provide. And Carter would claim that she was a scientist and not a spook. Jack didn't count on Entrapta to take a side in this anyway.

Not that the Alliance was a democracy, of course. Adora was the Supreme Commander, and you'd need a lot of political support in the Alliance to force her to adopt such a plan. If the princesses agreed with Adora - and Jack was pretty sure most would - then that wouldn't happen.

He sighed. "Let's discuss this when we know more about the situation. We have a few rebel Jaffa to contact."

"They are currently on PZ-9132, an uninhabited planet according to our files," Carter said. It had a breathable atmosphere, at least.

"We don't have spy bots there, but if the Jaffa dial in, we can route the comm to us here," Entrapta added, "and talk to them with some lag."

"Giving away that we're not near the Stargate," Jack said.

"We don't want to give that kind of intel to people who might be working, knowingly or not, for Apophis," Catra said.

“Then we travel back. We need to know more about this,” Adora said.

“And we need to decide how we play the Horde attack on Earth,” Jack reminded her. “Before Apophis’s stealth ships arrive there.”

She frowned but nodded. “We can do that on the way. Let’s go.”

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Alliance Forward Base, PU-9841, February 8th, 2000 (Earth Time)

The forward base securing the Stargate hadn't changed since they had passed through two days ago. Prefabricated walls surrounded a bunker containing the Stargate and several auxiliary bunkers housing the garrison, supplies and command and control structures. There were no heavy weapon emplacements - the ground forces’ task was to keep intruders away and handle assaults through the gate, not defend against a planetary invasion from orbit. That was what the flotilla in the system was for.

Still, Adora knew that while it wasn’t a huge commitment, it was still a sizable force just to secure a quick way to reach PU-9623. Relatively quick - it still took a ship a day to make the trip. And while the flotilla wasn't expected to defeat an all-out attack by a major Goa'uld fleet, it still had to be large enough to be able to stall such an invasion long enough for the garrison to evacuate through the Stargate - provided said Stargate wasn't blocked by another gate dialling in, of course.

All in all, it tied up a significant number of forces and logistical efforts just to cut down on travel time for key personnel such as Adora and her friends to PU-9623 and the bases on it. That hadn't been too much of a concern when the Alliance had expected the operation to be a temporary incursion, perhaps a large-scale raid to destroy whatever Apophis was preparing there, but now that they had to protect Beta, things had changed.

“We need to move this Stargate,” Adora said as the shuttle carrying them touched down on the landing pad inside the base.

“I've been saying that for some time,” Catra commented as she got up from her seat. “As have others.”

Jack made an agreeing noise, and Adora rolled her eyes. He had been less chatty than usual during the trip. He was probably still annoyed about her stance on diplomacy.

“But we’ll have to thoroughly check if there really are no natives on the planet,” Adora went on.

“Scans didn't show any settlements or other signs of a population,” Sam said.

“They could be hiding - they're close to the Goa'uld Empire and might even be refugees,” Daniel added. “If they don't use Naquadah or other advanced technology and are a small community, they would be hard to detect, right?”

“Yes,” Sha're agreed. “The Goa'uld would usually not care much about a few slaves fleeing, at least not to the point of expending a significant effort to track them down. If they hide underground or under cover like in forests or jungles, they would be safe from anything but a dedicated hunt.”

Adora pressed her lips together as the ramp was lowered. To live like that, in permanent fear that ships descended on you from the skies, that soldiers would come to hunt you down, should you be detected… That would be worse than growing up in the Horde.

“Even with our best sensors, it will take a long time to check the planet,” Sam said.

That didn't matter. They had to do it. They couldn't take the Stargate if there were people it belonged to. Adora returned the salute of the officer in charge of the base - Major Hawthorn, an American - and started formulating the orders for the flotilla and garrison to search for natives.

*****

Samantha Carter was secretly quite glad it wasn't up to her to scan the planet for natives. It wasn't that difficult, but it was very, very tiresome to run scans covering an entire planet. Scans detailed enough to find not only humans but potentially other sapient life forms took time. Sure, you could do something else while you waited for the scanners to finish their work, but only within limits. There were always checks and adjustments to make. Potential hits to examine further before they could be dismissed - the software was good but not perfect, and Sam knew you couldn't fully trust any automated system for such tasks. Not all the checks were strictly necessary, of course, but Sam would feel as if she was neglecting her duties if she didn't focus on the task.

No, it would be up to the clones in the ship to handle this, with support from the ground garrison. However, if they found something out of the norm, Sam knew she would be called in if she was still on the planet. If it was something dangerous or exotic, she'd be called in even if she wasn't on the planet.

And that suited her just fine.

In the meantime, she focused on the Stargate ahead of her. It was, as usual, blocked to prevent unauthorised access. Not with something as sophisticated as the iris back on Earth, but by being mounted on a frame that lowered it to ground, face down, when not in use. Simple and efficient, perfect for such field bases.

But if they wanted to talk to those Rebel Jaffa - well, if they wanted to let them call in, at least - they needed a barrier that allowed the wormhole to form but prevented physical travel through it. And lacking an iris, Sam would have to install the next best thing - a force field strong enough to handle that.

Fortunately, Entrapta and Sam had already solved that problem - a bot of Emily's size could handle that with a modified force shield projector. At least long enough for all practical purposes. All Sam had to do was to check if the field was properly placed and stable.

And it was. She switched it off, then turned to the General and Adora. “Force field ready to deploy.”

“Alright!” The general nodded. “Dial in.”

Sam pushed a button and the Stargate rose into a vertical position, the force field already securing it.

Daniel started entering the address on the D.H.D., and soon, the wormhole formed, then stabilised - and Sam deactivated the forcefield. With the wormhole active, travel to the gate here was impossible so the field was not needed right now. “The Stargate is open.”

“Let's call our rebel Jaffa,” the General said.

“Opening a channel,” Sam replied. The communicator quickly established a connection with another on the other side. “Frequencies and codes match,” she reported.

The General nodded and turned towards the screen linked to the communicator. “Put them through.”

Sam did a last check to ensure Adora, Catra and Melog weren't visible on the camera feed - they were known to Apophis after the raid on his palace, but they didn't want to show their hand at the start of the meeting - then accepted the video connection.

A Jaffa with a scar across his forehead - a wound from a blade or claw, Sam noted, not from removing a brand - appeared, in front of a landscape without any signs of inhabitation and only a few scraggly trees. He inclined his head. *“Greetings, Tau'ri. Teal'c.”*

“Hello,” the General replied.

Teal'c nodded as well but didn't address the Jaffa by his name. So, he didn't recognise him. That meant the Jaffa hadn't been a high-ranking member of Apophis's forces when Teal'c had been his First Prime.

“Hello.” Daniel smiled.

Sha're, however, had narrowed her eyes and took a step forward. “Kul'et.”

The Jaffa - apparently Kul'et - tilted his head to the side. *“I know who you are, but I do not know your name.”*

“Sha're.”

Daniel reached out and caught her hand, Sam noted.

“So…” The General looked at Sha're, then at Kul'et. “You know each other.”

“He was a guard at Apophis's palace. A low-ranking guard,” Sha're said. “He often punished slaves.”

“On my superiors' orders,” Kul'et replied, looking at her steadily.

“Just following orders,” the General said, baring his teeth.

“Like others.” Kul'et nodded towards Teal'c.

Teal'c returned the nod. “Indeed.” He didn't flinch.

Sam saw that Catra tensed up, though, and Adora patted her shoulders while Melog pressed against her leg.

“But now you've rebelled against Apophis,” the General went on.

“Yes.” Kul'et straightened. *“I had the opportunity to desert when I was sent to serve on another world. I and a few others took it.”*

Sam frowned. A demotion? If he had served at Apophis's palace, he might have been amongst those Jaffa punished after the raid that freed Sha're. It wouldn't be an unusual reason for someone to switch sides, though it didn't make for the most loyal allies.

“And you've heard about a threat to our world as well,” the General went on with a polite smile. “Quite fortunate.” He didn't

bother to hide the scepticism.

"It was fortunate indeed," Kul'et replied. *"A friend of mine overheard Apophis's orders to his Prime and told me. News of a new enemy spread quickly."*

Sam glanced at Teal'c, who inclined his head slightly again in apparent agreement.

"Apophis needs to work on his opsec," the General commented with a grin. "I won't complain though when it makes our life easier."

"Then you are prepared for this attack?" Kul'et tilted his head to the side.

Is he fishing for intel, Sam wondered, or is this mere curiosity - or even genuine concern?

The General snorted. "We've been expecting an attack ever since we sent Apophis running last time."

"According to what I heard, this enemy destroyed a far more powerful force than two Ha'taks," Kul'et said.

"Thank you for the warning. We appreciate it." The General's confident smile didn't change. "But enough about us. What about you?"

Instead of responding, Kul'et raised his eyebrow remarkably like Teal'c liked to do.

"What are your plans now?" the General elaborated. "You've deserted from Apophis and warned us. We owe you for that. What do you want?"

Kul'et stood ramrod straight. *"We wish to know where we can find the Goddess She-Ra so we can enter her service. She has proven to be far more deserving of our worship than Apophis."*

Sam glanced at Adora and saw that she was sighing. Catra was smirking, though - and Melog had changed colour, indicating amusement as well.

The General glanced at Adora as well, and, after a moment, she nodded, expression firm again.

He grinned in return. “Well, you're in luck, Kul'et.”

Adora stepped into the field of view of the camera. “Hello.”

And Kul'et dropped out of view of his camera. *“Goddess.”*

“Did he just kneel down?” the General asked.

“That would be an expected reaction to meeting a goddess, Jack,” Daniel said.

Adora sighed again.

*****

Catra snickered at the sight of an empty screen, but it wasn't that funny. Well, it was pretty funny to see Adora's reaction - her love was muttering about not being a goddess as if that would impress anyone - but Kul'et dropping to his knees didn't actually prove he was honest. Apophis knew about people worshipping Adora as a goddess after his palace had been raided and she had healed half his capital when she had restored magic to the planet. It didn't take a mastermind to connect Adora to Earth when she had been with SG-1. So, ‘pretend to worship She-Ra’ would be a no-brainer for any spy of his trying to infiltrate the rebel Jaffa - or Earth. But that didn't take into account that there were ways to check if the faith was genuine.

She glanced at Melog, who remained at her side.

Funny.

That made her snort again. “We'll have to meet them.” If only so Melog could take a closer look at them - he couldn't sense their emotions through a Stargate.

“If this is a trap…” Jack whispered.

Adora meanwhile took a step forward. “Please rise, Kul'et.”

“As you command, Goddess.”

Catra resisted the brief urge to tell him that ‘Your Divine Highness’ was the official address in the Church of She-Ra. She'd let Priest do that if the guy turned out to be an honest deserter. Heh, what if there was a schism in the Church over how to call Adora? It wasn't as if they listened to Adora's wishes in the matter, so she wouldn't be able to settle it…

On the other hand, church schisms tended to become very violent according to Earth history, so maybe that wouldn't be funny at all.

“I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. I am no goddess,” Adora said.

Kul'et didn't even flinch. He bowed his head instead. *“There is no need to test my faith, Goddess. Your deeds prove your nature.”*

Catra narrowed her eyes. Priest and his missionaries went on about how you couldn't have faith without doubt, so Adora denying her divinity was necessary to have faith in her, but how would Kul'et come up with this by himself? If Apophis knew about the Church of She-Ra, he'd also know that the clones were allied with Earth. And if Priest had somehow sent undercover missionaries to Apophis's realm, the Alliance would know about it. Probably.

She made a mental note to look into this.

Adora sighed, and Catra reached over to squeeze her hand while the tip of her tail ran over the back of Adora's thigh.

“How many are in your group?” Adora asked.

"We are but three, Goddess, but we know that there are others still within Apophis's ranks who worship you as well, and their numbers are growing. We decided to desert to warn Earth about this new threat while they stayed. If all of us had attempted to desert, it would have been too great a risk."

A likely story, and yet… Catra couldn't help thinking it was a bit too smooth.

Explains too much.

Melog agreed, then. Of course, Kul'et had grown up in Apophis's service. He probably had to quickly learn to come up with excuses for any potential failure when facing his god - or goddess. Still…

"Let's send in the spy bot and check for an ambush," Catra whispered.

Jack nodded and turned to Sam. "Send in the scout."

Outside the camera's field of view, the spy bot waiting next to Sam started to hover, then flickered and vanished as the stealth generator went active.

Catra watched and caught a slight ripple when the invisible bot passed through the gate.

"Who else is with you?" Adora asked.

"Man'ot and Bre'kul, Goddess," Kul'et replied.

Catra glanced at the screen in front of Sam. The bot was transmitting, and she could see two more Jaffa waiting, one on each side of the gate.

They stepped into view, bowing their heads. They looked a little younger than Kul'et. And a bit more nervous. *"Goddess."*

"I'm not detecting any other life forms nearby nor any hidden energy signatures in the vicinity," Sam reported. "The bot doesn't

detect any ships in orbit either.”

That didn't have to mean anything, of course - the bot's sensors were good, but it wasn't a deep space spy bot meant to spot enemy vessels.

But it was, as Catra had known, good enough for Adora. “I'm coming to meet you personally,” she told Kul'et, already walking towards the ramp.

“Goddess!” Kul’et fell down on his knees again - Catra watched it on the feed from the bot - as did the others.

Then Melog and she went after Adora. She might not be She-Ra, able to tank whatever the three Jaffa were carrying, and probably whatever might be hiding in orbit, but she wouldn't let Adora alone on another planet.

The air on the other side was dry and smelt slightly stale, somehow. Which was strange since they were on an open plain surrounded by desert. Well, they weren't here for that. All three Jaffa were still kneeling, not even looking at Adora.

“It is an honour to meet you, Goddess. We have dreamt of this but dared not hope…” Kul'et said.

Hate and fear.

Melog softly growled at Kul'et, then turned to the other two.

Happy. Relieved.

So, one spy and two dupes.

Catra bared her teeth in a smile and stepped closer to Adora.

*****

Gate Area, PZ-9132, February 8th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill couldn't help feeling a little apprehensive when he stepped through the Stargate. Sure, Carter had scouted the other side with her spy bot and found nothing, and Adora had already stepped through the Stargate and nothing had happened, but you could never be completely sure there was no trap. Especially when it came to the snakes. And this Kul'et just was a bit too smooth for Jack. So, he was prepared for an ambush when he walked down the ramp.

Not that he would show anything but confidence, of course, the better to unnerve his enemies and bolster the morale of his troops. "So… nice place here. Love what you did with the porch."

The three Jaffa blinked, confused, Adora frowned at him, and Catra snorted. She was tense, though. And so was Melog - the alien's illusionary fur was bristling, and they were glaring at Kul'et as if they wanted to pounce on the Jaffa and savage him.

Which meant that Catra was feeling the same. So, Kul'et was a bad guy - Melog had come through. Fortunately, Kul'et wasn't aware of Melog's powers or he'd probably realise that the jig was up.

"Just a joke," Jack said.

"A bad joke," Adora added.

Jack made a point of pouting but used the distraction to make eye contact with Catra and raise his eyebrows.

She nodded at Kul'et and signed 'one enemy' behind her back, then signed 'two' and 'friendly'.

Jack kept smiling. So, Kul'et was a spy. And didn't know they had seen through his act. Any spook back home would claim that spies you knew about must be left in place so you could feed them misinformation. They loved playing such games.

But this was a bit bigger than the Cold War. The stakes were a lot higher, and the most crucial information - the Alliance with Etheria

- couldn't easily be hidden from someone you supposedly trusted. They would have to keep Kul'et away from any important base much less Earth. And they would have to keep such tight control over what and whom Kul'et could see that, as a trained spy, he would very quickly realise that he had been made.

So, time to do the fun thing. Jack bared his teeth in a wide grin. "Say, Kul'et, did you get a cool secret decoder ring when you were trained as a spy by Apophis? I've always wanted one, but I never got one as a kid."

The two other Jaffa blinked, mouths hanging open. Kul'et did the same but blurted out: "What? I'm not a spy. I was a guard."

Adora frowned at him, and Catra said: "We *know* you're a spy. You can't hide your true allegiance from us."

Kul'et face twisted into a snarl and a zat appeared in his hand, but before he could raise the weapon, he was buried under about two hundred pounds of alien cat. Three hundred if you included Catra breaking said arm a moment later.

The other two Jaffa were frozen, then dropped to their knees again. "We didn't know, goddess! He fooled us!"

"Please believe us!"

And Adora, as expected, turned to beam at them. "Don't worry - I know you two are honest."

Relief - and awe - appeared on their faces for a brief moment before they bent down again, pressing their foreheads into the ground.

"Yes, Goddess!"

Jack shook his head as he moved to search and cuff Kul'et. Adora really needed to learn how to talk to impressionable Jaffa and other people without making them think she was a goddess who could see into their souls or something.

“And she wonders why people worship her,” Catra muttered as they went through Kul’et’s clothes together, removing several hidden gadgets.

Jack snorted again, then took a look at a miniature communicator that actually looked a little bit like a secret decoder ring if you squinted. “Looks like Apophis did hand out the good stuff to his spies.”

He tapped his radio button. “Anything we didn’t find, Carter?”

“No, sir. You should have everything according to our scanner.”

Jack grinned. It was good to know he could still search an enemy without a high-tech scanner to help. “Let’s get him back through the gate so we can interrogate him properly.”

Kul’et gasped. “Praised be Apo…urk!”

Jack drew back - Catra had just broken the Jaffa’s jaw and was pulling it open, revealing blood and… foam? Kul’et was jerking, and his eyes were rolling back - and then he went slack…

Jack cursed under his breath. Secret communicator rings and hollow teeth filled with poison - Apophis was hitting all the cliches.

“No!” Adora yelled, raising her sword - but not to point it at the spy. Instead, she raised it to the sky.

“No!” Jack spat, tensing. “Not again!”

But he could already feel her releasing the magic of this world.

And there it came. Jack clenched his teeth when Adora pointed her sword at Kul'et, bathing the spy in golden light that left him staring open-mouthed at her. The foam was gone as well, vapourized, Jack noted.

And then Adora turned, and Jack felt and saw the magic rush out of her, like a flood washing over the ground - and shooting into

the air. And for a moment, he felt as if he could lift the Stargate and carry it around.

Then the desert around them changed, plants shooting out of the ground. Grass, bushes, flowers. Trees. Instead of in the middle of a desert, they were now standing in the middle of a clearing, surrounded by a thick, lush forest, and the stale, dry air was now a gentle breeze with a flowery scent.

“All it lacks is Bambi and Disney would sue,” Jack muttered as he took a few deep breaths.

Catra's ears twitched. “What about birds?”

“Birds?” Jack blinked, then frowned. Now that she mentioned it, he could hear birds chirping. So, maybe there was an alien Bambi in the woods as well.

The two other Jaffa stared at the sudden change of scenery, then went back to pressing their foreheads against the ground.

“Goddess!”

“Praised be She-Ra!”

But Jack looked at Kul'et. The spy was trembling, his lips moving without making a sound, and his eyes darted around until they locked on Adora, who was lowering her sword with a sigh before turning to frown at Kul'et.

“We don't torture prisoners. We don't kill spies, either. You will be treated humanely. There is no need to kill yourself.”

Kul'et was staring at her with wide, frightened eyes.

“And we won’t let you kill yourself,” Catra added.

“G…. goddess,” Kul'et whispered.

Melog changed colours and looked at Catra, and Jack heard her chuckle for a moment. “Looks like you converted him, Adora.”

Adora blinked at her, then looked at the trembling Kul'et, who was trying to bow but was still held in Catra's grip, then at the two other Jaffa on the ground, and finally at the forest surrounding them.

“Oh.”

“Yeah, ‘Oh’,” Jack commented.

*****

Alliance Forward Base, PU-9841, February 8th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“You partially terraformed the planet.” Sam sounded fascinated, in Adora's opinion. “The forest covers a similar area as the original Fright Zone on Etheria, as far as we can tell - the spy bot’s sensor range is a bit limited at the moment, I've requested more bots to explore the planet but they will take some time to arrive. More importantly, it seems that you changed the atmosphere. It's now much more humid as before, at least in the gate area. We need more readings, though, and samples to check if it's a lasting change and what exactly happened. If the oceans are affected as well, for example.”

Adora winced at Sam’s words. She hadn't meant to do that. “I only wanted to save Kul’et's life,” she whispered. She hadn’t been sure her normal healing magic would’ve been enough, but the Jaffa shouldn't have to die because he was ordered by Apophis to avoid being captured.

“Well, you did. But I think you went a bit overboard,” Jack said in a dry tone. “Changing the entire world to save a spy is a bit much.”

“It is an uninhabited world,” Adora defended herself. “I didn't alter someone's home without asking them.”

Catra snorted, leaning against the console next to the Stargate. “You wouldn't have let him die anyway.”

Adora pouted at her. “Well, no, I wouldn't have.” That would have been wrong. Besides, they had to restore magic to all the worlds from where the First Ones had taken it away anyway. And there had been something wrong with the planet's atmosphere. Adora didn't know what exactly, but most of the magic had gone into healing that.

“But all that magic…” Jack trailed off with a frown, and Adora saw him rub his arms.

“Are you OK?” she asked. Had the magic she had done hurt him?

“Peachy,” he quickly said. “Just a bit tingly still from all the magic thrown around.”

“Oh?” Sam looked up from her screens and turned to Jack. “‘Tingly’?”

“Just… a figure of speech,” Jack said, looking warily at her.

“You might have been more seriously affected by Adora's magic, sir,” Sam said, taking a step towards Jack. “We need to examine you.”

“I’m fine, Carter.” Jack crossed his arms.

She narrowed her eyes at him. “I think that remains to be determined, sir. Healing magic - shouldn't have any adverse effects on your health, but there could be some changes.”

“Changes?” Jack looked very wary, and Adora bit her lower lip. She hadn't meant to hurt anyone!

“Changes. Adora seems to have created an entire ecosystem on the planet, including animals,” Sam explained. “We need to get genetic samples for analysis so we can determine if they're copies of existing species or new species - maybe evolved from present

species, though we don't know what those are either. I assume that biologists will be busy for years on the planet."

Catra snorted again, and Adora blushed. She hadn't meant to do that. She had just wanted to save Kul'et.

"Maybe we should name the planet 'Adora's World'," Jack suggested. "If it's going to be so important."

"I think we should leave that to whoever eventually settles there," Adora said. A world named after her? That was… too much.

"Jack's just trying to distract Sam from scanning him," Catra said.

Adora frowned at him. As did Sam. He grinned, though it looked a bit weak.

"Sir…" Sam shook her head. "We need to know if you were affected."

Jack sighed. "Alright. Do your thing, Carter. At least you don't use needles."

"I'll need to take blood samples as well, sir."

"Gah."

*****

The Double Cross Part 3

Alliance Forward Base, PU-9841, February 8th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“So, what's the verdict, Carter?”

The General sounded flippant, but Samantha Carter could tell that he was at least a little nervous behind his wide, cocky grin - his eyes gave it away. She knew him too well to be fooled.

“Well, sir…” she started to say, then wanted to wince when she saw his expression grow serious at once. He knew her too well not to catch on that she didn't bring good news.

And then he was grinning again. “If I am mutating into a dog, I'll need to know so I can make arrangements to get my uniforms altered.”

She snorted at that. “You're not turning into a dog, sir.”

“I sense a ‘but’ coming.”

“Your vitals are all good.” Great, even, for his age. Or for any age.

“Still not feeling reassured. Come on, tell me the bad news.”

She winced and sighed through clenched teeth. “I’ve detected some changes in your body on a cellular scale.” She took a deep breath. “Your DNA is… changing.”

“That sounds like a mutation.” He was dead serious now. “Unless X-Men lied to me.”

She didn't bother laughing at his joke. “It's not a mutation - it's more an… optimisation. I need to run it past an expert to confirm, but my preliminary estimate is that minor faults and defects in your DNA are being…” Don't say ‘fixed’, she reminded herself. “Corrected.”

“By magic.” He was pressing his lips together with such effort, they formed a thin line.

She nodded. “That needs to be confirmed as well, but it is the most likely explanation.”

He scoffed in return. “So, someone's cleaning up my genes. I guess I won't have to worry about all the radiation I might have picked up in places I never visited in the first place.”

Sam shook her head. “Any such lingering or potential health issues were already taken care of when Adora healed you the first time, sir:”

“Ah.” He narrowed his eyes. “So, what exactly is happening now?”

“I have yet to confirm it,” she said. “But my best estimate after using the most detailed magictech scanner I have access to here is that your, ah, Ancient heritage has been rendered more prominent.”

“I'm turning into an alien?” He stared at her.

“Not quite. It's more that your, ah, Ancient genes are becoming more dominant,” she explained.

“That sounds like I am turning into an alien, Carter.”

“The Ancients were, as far as we know, and as far as DNA tests have confirmed, our ancestors, sir. They were and are, in Adora's case, close enough to humans to have viable, non-sterile offspring, according to Alpha's data. That means we're the same species.”

“That sounds like semantics.”

“Scientific definitions aren't semantics, sir,” she reminded him, frowning slightly.

“That's what a semantic would say.”

“You're not turning into an alien,” she repeated herself. “And you won't suddenly sprout, ah, tentacles. As far as we can tell, you're simply becoming a bit more… like your ancestors. DNA-wise.”

He snorted. “Still sounds like turning into an alien. Will I get a magical sword or tiara?”

She hesitated a fraction of a second, but it was enough for him to pick up. “Don’t tell me I'm turning into a princess!”

“There's no sign of that as far as I can tell with my current equipment, sir,” she retorted.

“That's not a ‘no’, Carter.”

“It's as much as I can do here. We have to travel to Etheria and have you examined there.”

“By the crazy Frankenstein AI on the moon, you mean.” He scoffed and looked at the screen on the wall showing muted news from Earth on a lagging loop.

“And by the experts from Mystacor,” she added.

He turned to stare at her. “Right. Forgot about them. So, I'm turning into a witch?”

She winced again. That this would strengthen what, according to Castaspella, was already a high potential for magic was her best hypothesis. “I think the correct term would be ‘sorcerer’, sir. Though unless you start training in sorcery, you won't be able to actually work magic.”

“And that's how I like it!” he snapped. “Not a word to anyone with magic about that, Carter!”

“Sir! It's just a hypothesis so far. It could be something else. We need to have you examined by experts to be able to exclude the possibility that this might be a threat to your health.” She met his

eyes with a firm expression. “I cannot condone that risk.” And he should know better.

He stared at her for a moment, then sighed. “Alright. Let's get the Frankenbot to peek at my genome to check that I'm not turning into an alien.”

Sam didn't smile but merely nodded. But she was relieved. If she had to decide whether she would follow the General’s orders or her conscience, with his health potentially on the line… whatever the choice, she wouldn't have been happy.

*****

“So?” Catra turned away from the one-way window into the interrogation room where Kul’et was sitting - secured - at a table and looked at Melog.

Awe. Guilt.

That didn’t tell her what the Jaffa was feeling guilty about. Spying for Apophis on Adora? Or that he failed Apophis? He had been grateful, earlier, Melog had said - but that had been right after Adora had saved him from the poison he had taken.

She shook her head. “Looks like you’ll have to talk to him, Adora.”

Her love sighed but nodded. “I don’t know what would be worse - that he’s still faithful to Apophis or that he worships me.”

Catra rolled her eyes at her. “Stop whining. Every Jaffa that converts to the Church of She-Ra is one less Jaffa we have to fight.”

“I’m no goddess!” Adora clenched her teeth. “No one should worship me!”

Catra shrugged. “They do it anyway. Freedom of religion.”

“No one should be worshipped like that!” Adora retorted. “That kind of blind faith is what the Goa’uld want - and what makes them so evil.”

It was just a small part of why the snakes were evil, in Catra’s opinion. You didn’t need blind faith to get blind obedience. The Horde had shown that. And Earth had plenty of other examples. But it usually made it easier, of course. “It’s not exactly blind faith,” she said, grinning. “Priest certainly isn’t always listening to you. Well, he’s listening, but he doesn’t just do what you want.” Like when Adora wanted him to stop worshipping her.

Adora groaned. “That’s not a good thing either! I’m still responsible for him and his people!”

Catra scoffed. “You’d be responsible for them as Supreme Commander of the Alliance anyway.”

“It’s not the same!” Adora insisted. “This goes far beyond the military chain of command.”

Catra shrugged again. Sure, the clones would likely ignore any rules if Adora really wanted them to do something, but… “As long as they listen to you when it’s important, it’s a good thing,” she said. “Would you rather have them converting to an Earth religion? I’m sure many of their religious leaders would love having fanatical converts at their disposal.”

“Of course not!” Adora shuddered. “But… It’s just not right. And I don’t like to burden the next She-Ra with this responsibility.”

Catra pressed her lips together. The next She-Ra would only be chosen if Adora died. And Catra would do anything to prevent that from happening. But there was no need to go into that. She slowly shook her head. “She-Ra will do fine. Mara and you both had to deal with worse responsibilities.”

“And Mara died,” Adora spat.

Alright, Catra had been wrong. There was a need to get into this. "I'm not going to let you die. And if you're trying to get killed, I'll kill you!"

Funny.

Adora blinked. "What?"

"You know what I mean!" Catra said with a deep frown aimed at both her love and Melog.

Adora smiled even as she shook her head. "I'll go in now." She turned to the door leading to the hallway and left the room. A moment later, Catra saw her entering the interrogation room.

"Goddess!" Kul'et tried to jump up, but the chain fastened to his cuff stopped him. A moment later, he tried to bow but only managed to press his head against the top of the table.

Catra snorted - the Americans had installed the interrogation room, as a 'provisional measure', as they had called it, since they didn't want to move Kul'et to a standard P.O.W. camp until they knew whether he had ditched Apophis's faith or not, but they had done good work anyway.

She glanced at Melog for a moment.

Awe. Gratitude. Love. Guilt.

That sounded promising. Still, they had to be sure.

"Sit," Adora said.

"Yes, Goddess."

Catra saw Adora frown for a moment before smiling again. "How are you doing? Are you being treated right?"

He better be, Catra thought. If They couldn't ensure P.O.W.s being treated correctly in a tiny forward base under their very noses…

Well, technically, Kul'et was a spy, but since the Alliance had pulled off the same plots already, no one would make a fuss about that. No one who mattered, anyway.

Kul'et took a deep breath and bowed his head again. "I am being treated better than I deserve. I have done the bidding of a false god and attempted to deceive, to betray you, a true goddess. My life is forfeit!"

Guilt. Shame.

"He has been too long near Apophis," Catra muttered. "That's where he picked up all the drama."

Melog sent her a spike of amusement.

"No!" Adora shook her head, and Kul'et actually flinched at her tone. "No one is going to die for Apophis - or any other Go'auld - if we can help it. That includes you!"

"Your mercy is as vast as your power, Goddess."

Honesty. Relief.

Adora winced. "That's just doing the right thing. You were raised to believe in an evil cause. So was I. And others." She leaned forward, putting both hands on the table. "We understand. And we don't judge you for it."

Kul'et blinked. "I don't understand…"

Confusion, Melog confirmed.

Catra sighed. In theory, Kul'et could still be feeling all this and be loyal to Apophis. Relieved that they were treating him well, guilty for failing - or for having torn loyalties, maybe.

This could take a while. Maybe they should have called for professional interrogators. No - they wouldn't hold the same respect as Adora did.

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"...and so Melog came to the conclusion that Kul'et has honestly changed sides."

Jack O'Neill nodded at Adora's summary. "You mean he converted, right?"

Adora frowned at him, but Catra nodded. "Yes."

"That was likely the key reason he switched," Daniel cut in. "Adora saving his life in extremis, and changing a significant part of the planet at the same time, would have shaken anyone, of course, but Kul'et was especially receptive due to his background."

"The Goa'uld depend on power, both real and fictive, over their followers to keep them faithful," Sha're added. "But that means that should they be defeated by a rival, their followers might switch allegiance and faith to the victor because they might seem ascendant."

"And dear old Apophis has suffered a few humiliating defeats." Jack grinned. Some of them, like the losses of two fleets, he would have been able to keep secret from the general population, but Kul'et would have been aware of them since he was supposed to become a double agent. And Apophis hadn't been able to hide the raid on his palace. Now the Alliance just had to keep the pressure on, and Apophis's entire empire might crumble…

Of course, having the snake's faithful convert to worshipping Adora had some drawbacks as well, but they could deal with those once the snakes were done. "We've got Apophis fooled into thinking the Horde is about to attack Earth, and we turned his spy. How do we exploit this?" That was a question for the brass and spooks at Headquarters, but it never hurt to come back from the field with a few ideas and proposals. Especially if you were discussing it with the Supreme Commander of the Alliance.

"Kul'et had orders to gather what information he could, pass it back once he had the opportunity, and then wait for further

orders," Catra said. "So, we don't have to decide right now what misinformation he can pass back. But Apophis will have stealth ships on the way to Earth to watch the expected Horde attack. He might even move a fleet there in case there's an opportunity after the Horde and Earth destroy each other. We need to decide how to handle that."

Sha're nodded. "If Apophis thinks the battle was very costly for all involved, he won't be able to resist attacking the exhausted victor. Not only will he hope to recover Horde technology no matter who supposedly won, but taking Earth will enhance his prestige amongst his peers - and add a massive population to his realm."

"A population who will resist his occupation," Jack pointed out. "And we're rather good at making any occupiers' lives hell." Especially if they wanted to impose their religion on Earth. Hell, this would make Afghanistan look like a pleasure cruise!

"I doubt that Apophis would consider this," Daniel said. "That's not how it works in the Goa'uld Empire."

"He would expect the humans to bow to him once he has dealt with their leaders and armies," Sha're added.

"Then he'll be disappointed," Jack said. "We don't submit easily."

"His response will be brutal," Sha're replied. "He'll do anything to crush resistance. And Earth has so many people, he could kill a billion or more and still consider it a great addition to his power."

"Indeed," Teal'c said gravely.

"The loss of so many people would wreck Earth's industry," Carter objected. "The supply chains would already be in tatters after the Horde invasion, murdering more people…" She shook her head. "Earth might not recover in decades from such a blow."

"Fortunately, that won't happen," Catra cut in with a snort. "So, we have to fool Apophis into believing that either the Horde won easily or Earth easily defeated the Horde."

“If Apophis thinks Earth is strong enough to easily defeat an enemy who wrecked his own fleet, then he'll see us as much more dangerous than he thought - maybe a danger to the Goa'uld Empire,” Daniel said. “At the very least, he could portray us as such to his fellow System Lords.”

“He would try to set them on Earth in order to weaken both, just as he did with the Horde,” Sha're agreed.

“Guy's got no imagination,” Jack muttered. And the snake probably thought he was being clever instead of obvious.

“So, if Earth suddenly appears to be a great power in the galaxy, or at least tough enough to defeat the Horde remnants, that might cause the Goa’uld to address us with a united front,” Adora summed up.

“We don't want that,” Catra said.

“But a seemingly easy defeat of Earth at the hands of the Horde could have the same effect on the System Lords,” Daniel retorted.

“That would only mean a return to the status quo,” Sha're disagreed. “When Horde Prime was still alive.”

“But he was occupied with the First Ones back then,” Adora pointed out. “At least for the longest time. That wouldn't be the case now - if the Horde struck at Earth, the Goa'uld might expect them to strike at their own holdings next.”

Jack nodded. “And Apophis will try to use that as well to save his own neck.”

“It's still better than the alternative,” Catra argued. “The snakes won't know what the Horde might do, and how many are left, so they will be cautious until they find out more. So, we gain more time to prepare.”

“But the Goa'uld will prepare for a Horde attack. That means we'll lose the element of surprise anyway,” Carter said.

Catra shrugged. “That would happen sooner or later anyway. This way, especially with Kul'et on our side, we can control what Apophis will know, and through him, the other System Lords.”

It wasn't perfect by any means, and the brass and politicians back home wouldn't be happy, but that was war for you. Jack nodded. “So, let's think about how we can fake a Horde victory and occupation of Earth. Preferably one that makes Earth look like it's not worth another attack.”

“I don't think that's going to be possible,” Daniel said. “Earth has such a great symbolic value as Ra's ancestral seat, holding it, even if it lays in ruins, would benefit any System Lord.”

Jack frowned a little. “It's still better if Earth only has symbolic value rather than symbolic and economic and military value. So, any ideas?”

Carter suddenly stiffened. That was a bad sign - Jack was asking for ideas, not more problems. “Sir, I just realised there’s a problem with those plans.”

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, February 9th, 2000

“...and so we can fake an occupation of the Solar System by the Horde.” Adora smiled at the assembled Alliance leaders. “Since the majority of the ships protecting Earth are Horde frigates, we won't have to change our troop deployments. We'll have to be more careful with how we deploy Earth-made ships, but since the Goa'uld haven't encountered them yet, even if they are observed, they won't be associated with Earth.” And all of them were descended at least partially from Horde designs, so anyone analysing them without access to a captured ship would likely focus on the similarities.

The British Secretary of State for Defence nodded. “We might have to cover the ship's name and pennant numbers, though. And

the flags, of course.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. But that was standard procedure for any deployment anyway - at least until Earth's part in the Alliance was revealed. “We thought about using some of them to fake a naval engagement in the system to fool the stealth ships from Apophis which will be observing the Solar System.” Kul'et had confirmed that part. “ But that would hamper later deployment of the ships, and we don't want Apophis to think that Earth has naval yards - and that the Horde has taken them.”

Everyone nodded in agreement.

“Not that Earth has too many working naval yards to begin with,” Catra muttered next to Adora.

That was a bit unfair. Earth had many working naval yards. It was just that, with the exception of the British Flower II-class, they hadn't actually finished and commissioned any spaceships yet. The Americans were close with their Constitution II-class of frigates, though Sam had mentioned that their design still had some issues to be ironed out, and any fixes had to be applied to the other ships on the slips, delaying their completion. And the ships wouldn't be ready for deployment until they had enough space fighters to fill the hangars. The French were a bit more behind, but they were working closely with the British and last Adora had heard, they didn't expect too many troubles with their first design. The Germans were not quite as advanced, but they were both working on a stealth corvette and adapting the British transport design, so they had split their efforts. And, unlike the United States, the Europeans were all working with at least another, usually smaller country, which complicated matters a bit.

But that wasn't a topic for today's meeting. Adora forced herself to keep smiling as she went on: “But that won't help with the real problem: The radio waves Earth has been transmitting.”

She could see the assembled ministers react as they realised, some more quickly than others, what she meant.

“We've been broadcasting for years - including coverage of your arrival and the forming of the Alliance…” the American Secretary said, grimacing.

Adora nodded. “We've plotted how far the transmissions have spread, and while they haven't reached any systems occupied by the Goa'uld, and won't for decades to come, at which point they won’t be discernible any more, any ship sent to observe Earth from close by will be able to receive and understand them.”

“Like a radio telescope,” another minister said. “They'll be able to look into our past.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded again. “And we can't expand our sensor network fast enough to cover all that space. Not if we want it dense enough to spot their stealth ships.” Entrapta and Sam had been clear about that. Deep space was just too vast even for their magitech sensors.

“So what can we do?” the French minister asked. “If we couldn't do anything, you'd have started with that.”

“We can't count on spotting Apophis's stealth ships in space, and we can't stop the transmissions that were sent already. But his ships will need time to reach the Solar System. So, we need to ensure that when they arrive close enough to pick up the radio transmissions covering our arrival on Earth, Apophis cannot use whatever they receive any more.” She smiled as confidently as she could. “We’re planning to create a distraction so tempting, he won't be able to resist, and then we strike.”

“You want to take him out?” the German Minister asked. “A decapitation strike?”

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. “He's already suffered several defeats and is increasingly desperate. If we offer him a possible solution to his troubles, he's unlikely to resist.”

“And what are you planning to use?” The American Secretary was leaning forward.

“A Horde superweapon,” Adora replied. “One about to be used against Earth.” She saw their reaction, and clarified: “A fictive Horde superweapon constructed by us.” Leaking intel about it to Apophis would be tricky but not impossible with Kul'et's help.

“Ah.”

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Spacelab, Earth Orbit, February 9th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter brought up the latest schematics of Project Fortitude - she wasn't calling it ‘Project Death Star’ no matter what the General said - on the holoprojector inside the Spacelab. “This is what we currently have. If we use the Horde fleet trains manufacturing pipeline, we can build the hull from parts intended for the Velvet Glove mounted on a standard frigate. It would take a few days if we use an existing frigate, a bit longer if we purpose-build a frigate, though in that case, we could also adapt the structure and power generators for the project, which should enhance its effectiveness.”

Entrapta scrunched her nose while she studied the schematics. “Hm…”

Hordak tilted his head, then nodded. “It seems feasible. However, someone not familiar with the Horde would realise that it's not an original Horde design - Horde Prime would have never allowed such an aesthetically imperfect vessel to be produced.”

Samantha Carter pressed her lips together. She didn't think the design was that bad or ugly. “It's meant to be a prototype,” she defended her project.

“Horde Prime fixated on perfection. He wouldn't have shown, much less deployed, an imperfect design such as a prototype,” Hordak retorted. “Although I assume that Apophis is not as familiar with Horde Prime's character to know this, so this might work.”

“But it wouldn't work!” Entrapta blurted out.

Sam turned to look at her. “What's wrong with it?” she asked. Had she overlooked something? Missed a critical point?

“It wouldn't work! The ‘Core Cracker Cannon’ doesn't have enough power to actually crack a planet's core!” Entrapta shook her head. “It's just an upscaled regular beam cannon. But it's not upscaled enough. And the beam isn't focused enough to penetrate a planet's crust to the depth needed - in fact, the focussing crystal lenses are widening the beam. All this would do is create a hole in the ground, and not a very deep hole, either - the beam would lose cohesion way before it reached sufficient depth. You could continuously fire it for days and it wouldn't do much more!”

Sam cleared her throat. “It's supposed to be a decoy, not a working superweapon,” she reminded Entrapta. And a rush job. And it’s still more functional than the Navy's frigate design, she added in a fit of pique. At least this design would be ready to use sometime this year.

Entrapta frowned at her. “But if it obviously won't work, it won't fool anyone either!”

“I doubt Apophis would be able to tell that from the information he'll get,” Sam explained.

“We shouldn't underestimate our enemies!” Entrapta nodded at her own words. “Everyone says that.”

“We should not overestimate them either,” Hordak said. “I suffered a few setbacks early in my campaign when I misjudged the Alliance's response and had positioned my forces for a counter-attack that never came because they withdrew, and I had no forces ready to exploit that.”

Sam nodded, though she did feel a little torn about Hordak supporting her using his past as a warlord. “We can't exactly build a working superweapon for this,” she said - not for the first time.

“Well, we could, if we used an unstable dimensional portal, but deploying that from space is a bit of a challenge. It would be more like building a flying portal and landing it on the surface before activating it. And finding a way to replicate the dimensional interaction that allowed the portal on Etheria to almost destroy the planet would be tricky even with Beta’s support,” Entrapta said. “And that technology is banned, of course, because it's so dangerous,” she added.

The last line sounded a bit like Entrapta had learned it by rote to Sam, but that might just be her imagination. Still, better safe than sorry. “It was banned for a very good reason.” If research into something could destroy a planet - or more - if it suffered a mishap, you'd be insane or desperate to do it.

Or an Ancient, though their sanity obviously was in doubt.

“I concur. However, you said we could build a working superweapon?” Hordak sounded interested.

“Well, it depends on what kind of superweapon you want. If we combine the dimensional portal projector with the spy bot network for targeting, we should be able to compensate for the firing delay, but we would need to develop safe ways to quickly recharge the projector - it wouldn’t be very impressive if you couldn't fire it fast enough to destroy a fleet. It would need a larger housing and a lot more power than we can fit into the hull there, though.” Entrapta nodded. “And it wouldn't be able to destroy a planet unless you could keep at it until all parts were transported into another dimension, which would take a loooong time. It would be faster to just have a fleet bombard a planet, I guess, even if that wouldn't crack the core either. Anyway, it would probably not qualify as a superweapon. But! What if we combined a Naquadah-enhanced superbomb with a mass driver? Detonate it in the liquid part of the core of a planet, and the shockwaves should wreck the tectonic plates from below!”

Sam felt her stomach drop at the proposal. That was… theoretically possible. Building a bomb powerful enough to

achieve that wouldn't be too hard, but finding a way to deploy it to a planet's liquid core would be nigh impossible. “The bomb would never reach the core without being destroyed by the force needed to reach that deep,” she said. “And that kind of force would wreck the planet anyway.”

“Yes, that's the problem,” Entrapta agreed. “But if we manage to adjust the dimensional projector so the bomb is phased out of our dimension just long enough to pass through matter at the speed of a mass driver, it should phase back in just in time to detonate. The timing is tricky, and the speed needed is a bit above our current projections for such cannons, but if we focus on it, I think we could do it!”

“That would take a lot more time than we have,” Sam reminded her - and herself. “And we only need something that looks like a superweapon to bait Apophis.” Even though he already had a fleet to wreck planets with sustained fire. But a superweapon would appeal to his ego, according to the General. ‘They always go for the Death Stars,’ as he had put it.

“But it should look convincing!” Entrapta insisted. “So it needs to at least work in theory!”

Hordak nodded.

Sam sighed. “Let's see what we can do.”

This reminded her a bit too much of the US Space Navy design process.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, February 10th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“So, Entrapta and Hordak wanted to build an actual superweapon?” Catra snorted as she closed the message and looked at Adora. “To better fool Apophis?”

"Yes," her love sighed.

"A *Core Cracker Cannon*?" Glimmer had found the message as well.

"Sam's supervising," Bow said - a bit hastily, in Catra's opinion.

Justified, of course - Glimmer looked quite disturbed. Which also was justified - she knew, as did Catra, of course, how close Etheria had come to destruction because of 'superweapons'.

Catra pushed the memory away. "It's being handled. Besides, not even those three can build a superweapon as quickly as we need it. Just building the decoy will take a week if we screw up the logistics of our fleet."

"You sound remarkably unconcerned about that." Glimmer narrowed her eyes at her. "Especially after telling everyone how crucial those supply chains are."

"It'll be good training for when we launch the first offensive," Catra replied with a shrug. "Teach the Alliance to deal with the chaos of a campaign." Most of the Alliance members had never fought an interstellar war, much less on that scale. The clones had, of course, but it had been a while for them as well, and they would have to adjust to fighting in an Alliance. And without Horde Prime jumping into bodies to handle things in person. She flashed her teeth. "But, speaking of crucial things for the war…"

Glimmer scowled at her. "We haven't decided yet."

Catra rolled her eyes for a moment. "You mean you haven't decided yet if you want to stay queen."

"It's not that simple!" Glimmer defended herself. "Mom and Dad are still working things out."

Meaning, Angella was still trying to learn how to fit in after her return to Bright Moon, Catra mentally translated. She didn't say

that out loud, of course. Instead, she smirked. “So, that’s what you’re calling it in Bright Moon. ‘Working out’.”

“Catra!” Adora was blushing.

Glimmer, though, snorted. “They haven’t seen each other for over a decade and thought the other was dead.”

Bow looked a little embarrassed, but Catra nodded. “More seriously, though: We need to sort out our chain of command before we pull off a major operation.”

“I know,” Glimmer spat.

“And if Angella is too ‘busy’ with Micah to rule…” Catra trailed off.

“Nothing’s going to change for now,” Glimmer stated the obvious.

Catra shrugged and let the matter drop - for today. She’d return to it tomorrow, and keep at it until things were settled.

Adora cleared her throat. “Anyway, we’ve done preliminary planning with Priest for the space battle - a skirmish, actually. We’ll make a light show and have Kul’et leak that Earth has driven off an attack, but the Horde is bringing in a superweapon.”

“Why would we know that?” Bow asked.

“Because Hordak bragged about it to scare Earth into surrendering,” Catra explained. “But they won’t surrender, of course. Horde Prime probably wouldn’t have bragged like that, only after the deployment, but it would fit an underling trying to fill his shoes.”

“Priest wanted to write the dialogue, but Hordak declined,” Adora added with a wry smile.

“Is Priest working on the fake space battle?” Glimmer asked.

"Yes. Faking the weapons is easy - we'll just power down the beams some. But ideally, we'll need empty frigate hulls to blow up," Catra said. Or actual frigates, but blowing up a working frigate while Earth was struggling to build smaller warships and the Tok'ra had to make do with what small ships they had managed to scavenge and steal probably wouldn't go over well with the rest of the Alliance.

"Fake ships and a fake superweapon? That's a lot of effort and resources to fool Apophis," Glimmer said.

"We're not just fooling him - if all works out, we'll capture him," Adora said.

Or kill him, Catra added. Apophis wouldn't escape.

"You think he will visit the fake superweapon himself?" Glimmer frowned.

"He won't be able to resist," Catra said. "And then we'll get him."

"Ah." Glimmer nodded, then looked at her tablet again. "I think that's all the important stuff we had to cover."

"There are several important memos and reports left!" Adora protested.

"That can be handled by the staff," Glimmer said. "I'm not dealing with altercations between clones and Earth nutcases over religion. Not unless they turn into riots or someone gets seriously hurt. Or they become more frequent than once every two weeks. We're not going to run the war according to what Earth media are screaming about on any given day."

Adora pouted, but Catra nodded. Glimmer was right.

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Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, February 11th, 2000

"...and protestors have been gathering outside the local military base. They demand that the, and I quote, 'heathen aliens' are banned from visiting the county. So far, the commander of the base has not responded to our requests for a statement."

Jack O'Neill rolled his eyes. "That's because the whole incident has nothing to do with him or the base, you moron!" The clone whose proselytising had started all hadn't even visited the base. Nor had the 'Alliance military police unit' that had responded to save the clone bothered to check in with the base before breaking up the mob. No wonder the base commander was doing his best to keep out of the line of fire of this mess - no matter what he said, someone would take offence.

And it wasn't a big deal, anyway. The clones hadn't killed or seriously hurt anyone, even though they hadn't been gentle in dispersing the lynch mob. Not even the preacher who had riled everyone up. Jack wasn't sure if one of his commands had been able to do that, especially one that had only recently - as in five minutes before deployment, and Jack wasn't checking too closely if that had been backdated - been converted into a military police reserve unit. For once, Priest's skill at politics had come in handy.

Though Jack also couldn't shake the feeling that the clone missionary hadn't visited that particular town by chance. The clones usually stuck to big cities, at least in the USA. Or to the towns and cities outside the major Alliance bases - Brussels was about to build the first church for the Church of She-Ra, last he had heard, and the only reason Hamburg wouldn't beat it was that the German bureaucracy took longer to issue building permits.

Either way, it wasn't his problem. Or much of a problem at all. Despite the best efforts of certain members of Congress and parts of the media, those things never lasted long—something else Jack didn't really want to examine too closely.

He switched the channel and leaned back in his chair.

"...The United Nations General Assembly debated another resolution that would demand that control over the Stargate passes to a 'multi-national committee', as of yet not defined. It is not expected to pass but has the support of most African and Middle Eastern member states as well as Russia and China, and…"

In other words, no news from the United Nations. Some people just couldn't accept that they lost. As long as the sore losers stuck to trying to pass resolutions in the United Nations, nothing would come of it. And if they didn't and escalated… well, you'd have to be a suicidal moron to start anything with the Alliance if you didn't have a fleet of spaceships with big honking guns of your own. So far, even the Iranians had behaved rationally in the face of that.

"...the announcements of extensive naval exercises near Earth have raised concerns about the state of the war. The Alliance has not been very forthcoming about their operations, and rumours about a failed invasion continue to spread despite several statements of the Alliance Headquarters refuting them."

"...people demand the truth! What is happening out there? Where are our boys fighting? And whom?"

"...with the Alliance refusing to reveal where our tax dollars are going, fears of widespread corruption are common. Several experts have cited historical and current examples of how vulnerable autocratic governments such as absolute monarchies are to systematic corruption and voiced concerns about the Etherian members of the Alliance, especially in light that the vast majority of funding for the Alliance comes from Earth, and…"

Yeah, Earth funded the lion's share of the Alliance's costs - provided you didn't count all the spaceships. Or the frankly priceless support by their magical princesses.

Jack clenched his teeth. Damn! He didn't want to think about magic. He sat straight and gripped the closest memo on his desk. Already handled. As were the next two. He was actually up to date with his paperwork! And it wasn't a good thing.

He switched the channels again, but the report about local and global businesses profiting from the war was just rehashing things he already knew and did so in a particularly boring, buzzword-filled manner.

Not enough to keep him from thinking about magic. And Ancient genes. And subordinate scientists taking time out of their very busy schedules doing important research for the war to bother Jack about it. How often did he have to tell Carter that he was fine? No mutations, no weird magical effects happening - magic didn't start 'leaking' if you didn't use it. He had asked Castaspella that long ago. Besides, it wasn't as if Jack had magic. He had the talent to use magic if he wanted to. But he didn't want to.

Learning how to cast spells would take too long, anyway, even if he wanted. Jack would have to quit his post and move to Etheria. And that would mean leaving his people in the middle of the war, and good officers didn't do that.

Someone else, someone not Jack, someone who wanted to, could learn to do magic instead. It wasn't as if Mystacor had unlimited teachers, anyway. So, it was better to let others with the talent, younger people who weren't generals, learn magic.

Even if they didn't have the same potential as Jack.

He nodded at his reasoning. Not learning magic was the right decision.

A beep from his computer alerted him of another message arriving. Work!

Smiling, he opened the mail. Another proposal from R&D for special equipment for Special Forces? Those always were fun. "Let's see what they cooked up this time…" He blinked, then frowned. 'Special magitech equipment' sounded good, but 'dependent on a user's magical potential' sounded…

…like Jack had to ask a few people in the know a few questions about confidentiality. Pointed questions.

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The Double Cross Part 4

Solar System, near Earth, February 14th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Adora watched carefully as the shuttle flew alongside the hull to their side. Up close, the decoy superweapon did look impressive. At least if you had never seen Horde Prime's flagship before it had been turned into a plant. Adora hoped that Apophis wasn't familiar with the Velvet Glove. Even so, the superweapon was three to four times the size of a Horde frigate, which was impressive for a Horde ship. But compared to the superweapons Jack had shown them, it wasn't that big. Of course, those were fictive superweapons, not real ones. Then again, this was a decoy, so it wasn't a real superweapon either. Just real enough to fool Apophis. Hopefully.

And it was a pretty functional decoy. The hangar doors opened smoothly as their shuttle approached, and the forcefield keeping the atmosphere from venting into the vacuum barely flickered when the shuttle entered the hangar. Of course, none of the people involved in its construction would accept shady construction. The only part that didn't work was the Core Cracker Cannon.

They touched down, and Adora saw a formation of clones line up on both sides of the ramp as it descended.

“Supreme Commander!” the officer in charge of them saluted. “Welcome on board the Piledriver.”

Adora smiled at him and returned the salute.

“Hello, Adora! Hi, Catra!” Entrapta waved at them while Hordak and Sam, standing at her side, nodded. “How do you like the not-fully operational battle station?”

“Isn’t it a little small for a Death Star?” Catra commented with a grin.

Sam frowned at that, Hordak didn't react, and Entrapta pouted. “Jack made the same joke already,” she complained. “It’s not our fault! If we had had more time, we could have made it fully operational.”

Sam cleared her throat. “It's a fully functional *decoy*. It's not meant to wreck planets.”

“But Jack said…”

“The General was joking.” Sam pressed her lips together.

“Is he still carrying a grudge over the magitech weapon proposal?” Catra asked.

Adora frowned. “I thought that had been cleared up. The timing was just a coincidence; his medical data wasn’t leaked.” The research proposal had been written up before the… magic incident Adora was responsible for. And technically, it was Jack’s complaint that had revealed what had happened to him. Though it would be unfair to mention that to him.

“It's a sore subject,” Sam said in a tight voice.

“Ah.” Adora nodded, suppressing a wince.

“He'll come around once he can blast stuff with magic weapons,” Catra said.

Sam nodded with a faint smile. “I guess so.”

Entrapta, however, beamed. “Oh, yes! We've gone over the proposals - those will be great!”

Adora agreed, but they weren't here to discuss magictech gear. They were here to inspect the decoy superweapon. “So, show us

around?” They had seen the plans, but this was the first time Catra and Adora were on board the decoy.

“Of course!” Entrapta nodded several times. “Let's start with engineering! We've used a standard propulsion array, standard for a Horde frigate, so it's kinda slow, but we've improved the shields in exchange. And since the main weapon is a decoy, we could install a more powerful reactor, and so the shield is far stronger than a frigate's!” Entrapta led them down the hallway. “So, it can take a beating. But it's not actually that much better protected compared to a frigate - since it's so slow, it's also an easier target. Even with all the electronic countermeasures we installed. Though those are mostly to keep Apophis from detecting the hidden troop compartments. Which we built into the reactor room. The interference from the reactor and the shielding from it should help counter any sensors.”

Adora frowned. “Isn't the shielding supposed to protect us from the reactor's radiation?”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded. “But it will also block scans. And we left enough around the reactor, so it's still within Horde safety regulations.”

“Horde Prime's or Hordak's?” Catra asked.

“Mine,” Hordak told her.

“Good.” Catra grinned. “I wouldn't trust the safety regulations from Horde Prime.”

Adora nodded. That man had seen all his clones as expendable, after all. “And I can heal everyone afterwards, just to be safe.”

Catra snickered. “Jack will love that.”

Adora frowned at her - making fun about Jack's fear of being magically changed wasn't nice - but Sam nodded. Firmly. Maybe she carried a grudge as well about the misunderstanding?

Maybe Adora should talk to them. They shouldn't start a dangerous mission with such tensions in the team.

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Solar System, near Earth, February 15th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...So, the decoy battle station is fully operational?"

"Yes, sir." Samantha Carter kept her face impassive and didn't smile at all at the General's joke. "All systems are operational - including the shielded troop compartments." She pointed at the holographic projection behind her in the cabin currently serving as her office on the decoy.

"Which not even semi-portable scanners the size of a crate would find, right?"

"None of the known scanners the Goa'uld use can penetrate the shielding, sir," Sam replied. "All they will detect are the decoy readings we prepared - meaning, they'll see additional power supplies for the main gun," she added before the General could ask. "Although if you desire additional proof, you can attend the testing with the Tok'ra we've scheduled for later today."

"Ah, that won't be necessary. I trust you, Carter."

She pressed her lips together. As he had trusted her not to reveal his condition to others? She'd never break his confidence like that! It was petty, she knew, but he should have known better than even to ask.

Something of her thoughts must have shown on her face since she saw him wince for a moment. "So… everything's ready for the mission. All we need is Apophis to bite."

"Yes, sir."

"Good."

A moment passed without either of them saying anything. She didn't like how awkward it felt.

"So… if we needed, could you and Entrapta rig the main gun to actually fire?"

"The main gun is functional, sir," she replied. "It just doesn't have the power its size would indicate since most of its volume is taken up by the troop compartments and other secret systems. Otherwise, it's a standard main gun used on Horde frigates." He knew that.

"Yeah, I know. But could you, you know, have it shoot at that kinda power if we needed it? By overloading it, or something?"

"No, sir. That would merely melt most of the gun - including the troop compartments."

"Ah." He nodded, then grinned. "Good job on keeping Entrapta from making an actual superweapon. Wouldn't want to blow up a world by mistake."

She frowned at him. That was an unfair comment - Entrapta knew better than that. "The only way such a weapon would have been actually used would have been if Alliance Command decided to use it. Entrapta would never use it on her own." And Adora would never condone such a course of action. She would never sacrifice a world to win a war.

"Not even to test it?"

She frowned again. "None of us would test it on a planet, sir." It would bring up too many memories. Of Etheria's near-destruction. And of planets left destroyed at Horde Prime's command.

"Good." He sighed. "Several people who know about this operation are quite interested if such a weapon could actually be built."

“My report shows that it’s theoretically possible - provided quite extensive research proves the viability of several assumptions critical to the concept,” she said. “The cost of this research, both in resources and time, cannot be estimated with any degree of certainty at this point, but even the most optimistic estimate is substantial.”

“Yeah, I’ve seen the numbers. Though that won’t stop people who really want their second Project Manhattan. Especially if it results in an actual Death Star.” He shrugged. “Though some of them probably just want a big cut of the money which would poured into such a project and don’t care if it ends up working.”

Sam nodded. She was aware of this kind of… it wasn’t technically corruption, but you could make a case for it being embezzlement. Though given past practices in the USA with regard to procurement for the Armed Forces, it would just be seen as business as usual - few such projects did not end up costing far more than promised.

He shrugged. “Well, not this one. Our Etherian friends have a kind of chip on their shoulders about blowing up planets. The Alliance won’t be funding research into planet busters.”

Or other weapons of mass destruction, though the definitions of what was a weapon of mass destruction tended to be a bit fluid when it concerned space combat. Any weapon system that could destroy a large spaceship mounting force shields would easily lay waste to an unshielded city - or landscape. And if you had a fleet of ships designed for such battles, an orbital bombardment could destroy a planet’s biosphere.

“They wouldn’t take kindly to independent research into such weapon systems, either, sir,” she said.

“I know. And so does the President. But do you think this will stop Kinsey’s cronies?”

She pressed her lips together. "He has been quite vocal about not alienating our allies, sir."

"Yeah, which means he thinks he can distance himself from whoever is doing this if it gets out," the General replied.

"Such research requires highly specialised and experienced scientists, apart from access to advanced technology, sir. And actually testing even rudimentary power systems advanced enough to power such a weapon would show up on our sensors the moment they are switched on for the first time."

"I hope you're right, Carter." He shrugged. "But it won't stop people trying it. Ours, the Russians, the Chinese… Like every damn dictator who wanted nukes, they won't feel safe until they have something to make the Alliance back off from meddling in their 'domestic matters'."

Sam knew that. But she didn't think they would succeed. Not without a lot more advanced technology available and a lot more research. But she also knew that sooner or later, both would be available.

"Anyway, I've picked my teams for this mission. I'll send them up so they can get settled in." He nodded at her. "Good work, Carter."

"Thank you, sir. I'll pass it on to Entrapta and Hordak."

Another nod. He turned, then stopped. "Also… sorry about, you know. I overreacted."

She hesitated a moment, then nodded, smiling a little, and he left the cabin.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, February 15th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra felt surprised. And wary. She had been all set to insist on coming with Adora to the meeting about Bright Moon's crown, argue that they needed some outside opinion, from someone who wasn't a princess, who had different experiences and perspectives, and whatever other argument she could pull off without coming across as a blatant liar (such as claiming she wasn't biassed in favour of either Glimmer or Angella), but no one had said anything about her walking in at Adora's side.

In a way, it was almost disappointing. But she was in, and with Adora, and that was what mattered. Someone had to keep the bigger picture in mind. And keep Adora from being manipulated - Catra wouldn't put it past Angella to try to act like… like Shadow Weaver, all understanding and caring, and praising, when she wanted something. She still had to find out why, of all the Horde people, Shadow Weaver had been alive in the other dimension - and not exiled, but at court.

But that could wait until this was settled. Maybe a bit longer - with the decoy operation coming up as soon as Kul'et could credibly pass the information Earth supposedly had managed to find about the Horde Superweapon on to Apophis, Catra would rather not create a potential mess.

She sat down next to Adora, scooting her chair a bit closer so her tail could wrap around Adora's calf under the table. On Adora's right were Angella and Micah, on Catra's left Glimmer and Bow, both sides facing each other.

“This feels like a trial,” Catra whispered so only Adora could hear.

Her lover didn't say anything, but Catra felt her tense up. Damn. She had meant it as a joke.

“So!” Adora cleared her throat, smiling forcedly, and nodded at everyone and no one at the same time. “We're here to discuss the succession of Bright Moon's throne.”

“Also known as Bright Moon family therapy,” Catra quipped under her breath.

This time, Adora coughed and glanced at her with a small frown.

Catra knew she was right, though - this wasn't about precedent or law since Bow hadn't found anything about it. The only known case where a princess had returned after a successor had been enthroned had happened seven hundred years ago in a remote kingdom that wasn't around any more - the civil war that had settled the succession there had wrecked it, and the following conflict with Plumeria had resulted in the kingdom becoming part of the ruins found in the Whispering Woods.

No, this was about what Angella and Glimmer wanted.

As if she had been reading Catra's thoughts, Angella nodded and spoke up: “Yes. And as I have said before, this is Glimmer’s decision.”

Catra pressed her lips together. Angella kept insisting that only Glimmer's wishes mattered, but Catra couldn’t help wondering what would happen if Glimmer decided something Angella thought foolish. Well, at least she couldn't easily go back on her word after she had said this, so Glimmer had this in the bag.

“It's not just my decision,” Glimmer retorted.

Catra clenched her teeth and hissed under her breath. Of course, Glimmer just couldn’t run with it!

“It is. You are the crowned queen of Bright Moon. You passed the test - both on coronation day and by ruling the kingdom,” Angella said.

“That's a formality!” Glimmer spat. “I'm talking about family! You're my mom!”

Hah! Catra gave Adora a look that her lover pointedly ignored, though Catra could see her cheeks heat up a bit.

Angella looked taken aback a bit, her eyes widening for a moment before she nodded with a soft smile. “That doesn’t change anything. You're no longer a child, Glimmer. You have proven you are a queen. The kingdom prospered under your rule. Or do you disagree?”

Glimmer visibly clenched her teeth.

Catra stared at her. This was what they needed - full approval by the potential contender. Just accept it! she silently urged her friend.

“Look, it’s…” Glimmer trailed off, frowning. Probably at herself. “I only got crowned because you sacrificed yourself! Not because you thought I was ready for it!”

Once again, Angella looked surprised - maybe even a little confused. Well, so felt Catra. “And then you proved you were ready when you ruled,” Angella said while Micah nodded.

“I almost got Etheria destroyed when I listened to Shadow Weaver!” Glimmer blurted out. “I was just lucky things worked out as well as they did!”

Catra blinked, then snorted. “Join the club!”

“Catra!” Adora frowned at her.,

But Micah chuckled, ruefully. “Shadow Weaver was a master at manipulation. I think of all of us here, only Bow never fell for her lies.”

“Ah…” Bow blushed a little. “I did think she was genuine when she claimed to join the Alliance.”

“But she never manipulated you into making a really stupid decision,” Glimmer told him.

“She never tried.”

Adora was looking down at the table, Catra realised. Probably thinking about their childhood. And blaming herself for what Shadow Weaver had done. “Don’t be an idiot,” Catra whispered, reaching over to squeeze Adora's thigh. “It wasn't your fault. You were a kid.” Catra, on the other hand, had fallen for Shadow Weaver's lies even as an adult - she should have known better.

“I also trusted her,” Angella said. “Even when I stepped through the portal, I thought she had turned over a new leaf. To find out later that she had not changed, still pursued her own goals no matter the cost to everyone else…” Her lips formed a thin line. “If I had known that, I would have treated her very differently in the other dimension.”

Catra slowly nodded. That explained things. Not everything, of course.

“So we all fell for her lies. That still doesn't settle things!” Glimmer insisted. “What do *you* want, Mom?”

“I want you to be happy, Glimmer.”

“How can I be happy if I steal your throne?”

“You earned the throne, Glimmer. It's not stealing if I hand it to you voluntarily.”

“But…”

“Oh, hell!” Catra blurted out. “She told you you did fine! Now stop waffling and say you'll keep ruling Bright Moon so Angella and Micah can keep catching up on all the sex they missed!”

“What?” Glimmer gaped at her.

“Catra!” Bow gasped.

“CATRA!” Adora snapped.

And Angella stared, blinking.

But Micah laughed, wrapped an arm around Angella's waist and pulled her into his side. “She's right about that, Glimmer.”

“Dad!”

“Micah!”

Now both Glimmer and Angella were blushing like mad. Adora as well.

But Glimmer had shut up about trying to talk herself into not being queen.

Catra considered this meeting a success.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, Earth, February 16th, 2000

“I'm missing the healing potions,” Jack O'Neill joked as he put the file down on his desk.

Dr Leary, the scientist sitting across from him coughed. “We actually did consider such a project - there was some preliminary research into it since magical potions are relatively prominent in myths on Earth and also feature in various emerging magical traditions here.”

“I was thinking of the things in computer games.” Jack smiled as blandly as he could.

Leary grimaced, so he probably hadn't noticed that Jack was joking. That was par for the course - the man was overly serious. Why he had been sent to a meeting with Jack was anyone's guess. Maybe office politics. Or just politics - the man was working for DARPA, after all, which was one of the holy grails of any Defence lobbyist. “The obvious advantages of such an item are, well, obvious. But if we look at the existing magitech healing items, the risks of such are also apparent.”

“Yeah, we don't want people turning into zombies after curing a paper cut.” Jack nodded with a snort.

“Quite.” Leary smiled forcedly. “In any case, we did some preliminary research, but most of the healing potions, I mean the potions most similar to those which are worked on by practitioners of magic on Earth, are meant to, ah, cure sicknesses or alleviate some debilitating or painful conditions, instead of mending wounds.”

“Medicine, in other words. And we have lots of that already,” Jack said.

Leary nodded. “Indeed. Alternative ways to treat influenza or the common cold might appeal to a certain demographic, but unless such remedies are far more effective than current medical solutions, spending money on them would be a waste.”

Jack nodded. That wouldn't keep rich fools from spending a lot of money on such potions, of course. Magic was the new fad, at least outside religious circles, and anything magical sold like hotcakes.

“So, for now, it has been decided - mutually, Mystacor's delegation agrees - that the Alliance wouldn't finance research into, ah, healing potions or other magical potions. Recruiting sorceresses trained in healing magic should already be a priority for the Medical Corps, anyway.”

That didn't mean they had too much success at it, though - Jack had seen the numbers. Not even his command had received nearly as many such recruits as he had requested. And his people would be operating behind enemy lines and in other places where medical evacuation wasn't expected and really needed healers.

But that wasn't the point of this meeting. “Well, the magic items on the list seem interesting,” he commented.

Leary winced. “They're magitech tools.”

Jack shrugged. “They do magic when you activate them - or are supposed to. That makes them magic items.” His soldiers certainly would call them that. “And all the magitech items I know don't need special genes to be used.” He narrowed his eyes slightly.

“Ah, yes!” Leary perked up. “That's actually a result of the main difference between, say, the magitech scanner the Alliance uses and the proposed tools. With the scanner, you push the button, and it tells you what it scanned. Like a computer. With our proposed tools, activating the item creates a magical power of sorts, but it's up to the user to actually aim and use that power so it achieves the desired effect. And that requires a certain genetic disposition.”

“A talent for magic, you mean,” Jack said in a flat tone.

Leary nodded with a smile. “Exactly! People who could, with the right training, learn to cast spells.”

People like me. Jack drew a deep breath through clenched teeth. It had been a coincidence, he reminded himself, that the proposal had first crossed his desk so close after he had found out that his genes were changing. He had already overreacted and made Carter mad; he wouldn't make the same mistake again. “We generally want them to learn how to cast spells,” he said.

“Oh, yes.” Leary nodded. “That would be ideal, of course. But as you know, the opportunities for magical education are currently rather scarce, even with help from Mystacor. We can only send a handful of people to Etheria, and Earth's own magical institutions are still in the process of being built and not up to taking more than a few students for rather experimental lessons.”

“So, you'd rather use them for experiments with magitech?” Jack’s tone was, maybe, a bit sharper than it should have been, but he kind of had a personal stake in this.

“Yes!” Leary nodded again, smiling broadly. “If we can create such items, we can drastically shorten the time needed to field magical

support for our troops. All it would take is a recruit with the talent, magic gear and time to train with the gear - nothing too different from existing specialist training."

Any fool could see the advantages, and Jack wasn't a fool. And, of course, it would also mean that when the war was over, and the soldiers were getting demobilised, unlike trained sorceresses, those kinds of magic-using soldiers wouldn't be released into civilian life with the power to throw fireballs at their fingertips. Not until they trained as actual sorceresses, at least.

Yeah, Jack could see this proposal's advantages. Even if he didn't like it. "And how likely is this to work out? In time to be used in the war?"

Leary's smile twisted a little. "Well, it's a new field of research and development, so we can't make exact predictions, but we're quite optimistic that we'll see tangible results in time to be fielded. Mystacor's researchers are very interested in this as well, so we have experienced people working on this."

In other words, this could be pie in the sky. But the potential was so obvious, and with Etheria backing the idea, Jack knew trying to block this would be pointless. Better to get on board so he could keep an eye on this - he had mixed feelings about those 'tools', but he would rather not end up fighting zombified test subjects because no one ran herd on a bunch of mad scientists. If his people were to use those things, Jack would make sure they were safe. Even if he had to use his stupid alien genes for it.

So he nodded and gave Leary his best fake smile. "Well, you have my support, Doctor."

"Thank you, general!"

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Asteroid Belt, Arealis-System, February 18th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Adora looked at the crates being lowered to the deck of the ‘Steel Fist’ - Hordak's idea; he claimed the name would fit Horde Prime's naming scheme best - and managed not to wince. The bodies inside the containers had never been alive, so they weren't really corpses, and they hadn't been cloned in the Horde pods but had been grown in Alpha, but they looked the part.

That was a good thing, of course - in order to really fool Apophis, they couldn't just pretend the entire crew had evacuated; some corpses had to be left - but they really looked the part. Some were torn up, some showed the typical signs of ‘explosive decompression’, as Sam had called it, some were riddled with bullets… the ones that were supposed to have died from suffocation were the least bad to look at.

“They were really thorough in preparing this,” Catra commented, peering at the closest container's glass lid. She acted cool, but Adora could tell that she didn't like the sight either. “I'd be worried if I didn't know this was mostly Alpha’s work.”

Adora blinked. “You're not worried that Alpha did this?”

Her love shrugged. “We already know Alpha would do whatever she thought was needed for her projects no matter how wrong if she were allowed to.”

“Ah.” Adora nodded. Catra was correct - Alpha had been following their orders, well, Adora's, to the letter, but it was obvious that all she cared about was her research and that she had no moral or ethical restrictions. Not that that was her fault, of course - the First Ones had built her like this - but it was still a potential problem. And yet… “It's better than the alternative.” Some clones had volunteered to stay behind! Adora and Priest had set them straight, but that had been a shock. The last thing Adora wanted was for people to sacrifice themselves for her!

Catra checked her tablet. “Well, everything's proceeding according to schedule. Kul'et's report should be reaching Apophis today, unless his people are not quite as competent as we assumed.”

Adora nodded. And then, Apophis would think Stargate Command was about to launch a desperate mission to take out the superweapon before it could be deployed against Earth - using information that would allow him to swoop in and take the superweapon for himself. Everyone agreed that he wouldn't be able to resist the temptation to show up both the Horde and Stargate Command. And the timing was tight enough that Apophis couldn't hesitate too long, or he'd lose the opportunity - this system was just close enough for his forces to be diverted here instead of closing in on Earth.

But Adora couldn't help worrying that the timing might be too tight. Sure, the plan allowed for delays, and the scripted attack had several points where the supposed boarding action by Stargate teams would be stalled to give Apophis's forces more time to move in, but the plan was a bit more complicated than Adora would have liked.

"The Imperial Japanese Navy would have loved it," Jack had commented.

Daniel had disagreed with that, but his explanations had made it clear that Jack hadn't been that far off.

"So, the crew casualties are ready to be placed," Catra said. "And the bots should soon be done with the supply station on the ground. We're ready to move into the troop smuggling compartments as soon as we get word that Apophis is starting his operation."

Adora nodded and turned to look through the force field separating the cargo bay from space. She could see the hull that served as the Steel Fist's escort in the distance. It would be blown up as soon as the mission started. At least they didn't need any fake corpses for that part.

Everything was ready or almost ready. And yet… "I wish we could just go straight for Apophis," she said.

Catra shrugged again. “He's prepared for that. We won't be able to sneak into his palace again, and a frontal assault would cause too many civilian casualties - and allow him enough time to escape. But if he thinks he's fooling us, he'll be vulnerable.”

Adora knew that. The Alliance command council had argued about this almost as much as they had argued about Adora and her friends leading the mission. As if she'd let anyone else risk their lives without her when she was needed!

She just preferred a less complicated plan. Even cadets learned that you could never anticipate everything. You could just do your best and improvise when needed.

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Asteroid Belt, Arealis-System, February 20th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter stared at the holoprojection above her laptop, which showed the Arealis-System and the projected course of Apophis’s fleet, confirmed by the spy bot network. Five minutes out according to their best estimate.

She zoomed in on the asteroid belt with a few keystrokes. Tiny projections of the “Steel Fist” and its escort appeared, followed by even smaller projections depicting the two Tel’taks that had docked to both ships.

“Are they there yet?” the General asked. He was sitting back in his seat, hands on the back of his head as if he was bored, but Sam knew it was an act. Same as Catra’s ‘snoring’.

“Not yet,” she replied. “Approximately four more minutes.”

“You said that last time I asked!”

She snorted, once, and switched her attention to the screens showing the interior of the ‘Steel Fist’. The cloned corpses had been placed, and the boarding team was doing a good job of

shooting up the hallways around the bodies. They didn't stray too far from the airlock where the Tel'tak was docked, of course - they would have to retreat quickly once Apophis's ships arrived.

The team on the hulk serving as a decoy escort was doing the same, but since that hull would be blown up, they weren't quite as crucial for fooling Apophis's troops as the team here. If Apophis realised that this was staged…

She pressed her lips together. The stealth compartments built into the fake superweapon were shielded, but against sensors and small arms fire, and the shields of the "Steel Fist" wouldn't last long at all against a bombardment from multiple Ha'taks. If the "Steel Fist" came under fire, they would have to scuttle it using the charges built into the structure and hope that the debris would fool Apophis and allow the compartments housing Sam and the others to be picked up later. Entrapta and Sam had added stealth generators as a last resort, but even if they worked perfectly, they wouldn't stop a stray shot from hitting them.

Sam wasn't really fond of the odds she had calculated to survive this. At least if things went very wrong, not all her friends would die with her - Entrapta had been left behind to work on their projects with Hordak and the rest. It was just the SG-1, with Sha're, and the "Best Friends Squad" here, with two fire teams from the General's command added.

A beep drew her attention - and made the General and Catra sit up at once. "Enemy fleet exiting hyperspace in ten seconds," she reported.

"Showtime. Literally," the General commented with a toothy grin.

Then the holoprojection changed, fourteen Ha'taks appearing with two dozen Al'keshs surrounding them. She checked the distances - a few minutes, at most, until they would reach them. Two minutes for the Death Gliders already shooting out of their hangars.

The General wanted five seconds, then pushed a button on the radio in front of him. "O'Neill speaking! A Goa'uld fleet has just appeared. All teams, withdraw at once - the mission is scrapped!"

Another voice protested. *"Sir! We only need a few more minutes!"*

"We don't have them, O'Malley! Withdraw - this is an order!"

"Yes, sir!"

The General deactivated the radio and chuckled. "O'Malley must have been channelling his annoyance that he couldn't join us."

"Do you think Apophis is tapping into our radios, Jack?" Daniel asked.

According to Kul'et, the Goa'uld were monitoring the radio waves but didn't have the capability to break their encryption in real-time.

"It never hurts to go the extra mile," Jack said. "Though if he were, I think he would be taunting us right now. Or demanding our surrender."

"He might have decided that the risk of facing SG-1 again is higher than the danger of an underling betraying him and taking the superweapon for themselves," Teal'c commented.

"As long as he comes to check out his new toy as soon as he has secured it, that's fine," the General said.

Sam agreed. If they only had to fool his most fanatical Jaffa and not Apophis himself, that would improve the odds of their success.

The Death Gliders were racing towards them. Their speed was actually higher than expected, if not by much. Sam still frowned as she logged the data. Still not fast enough to reach the ships before the Tel'taks could undock and cloak.

Which the one docked to the Steel Fist just did, followed ten seconds later by the one docked to the escort. As both cloaked - their holoprojections changed colours - the fake escort blew up.

The Goa'uld fleet was still coming at them at full speed. The Death Gliders were firing blindly at the last position of the Tel'taks and the space around them. Fortunately, the cloaked ships had already gained enough distance that the shots went far too wide.

Sam turned to look at Adora. "Escape pods ready to be launched."

Adora nodded. "Do it."

Sam gave the order with a push of a button. The ship was too big to feel any reaction from the escape pods being launched, but she could see the pods, all of them carrying at least one cloned body, on one screen and track their courses on the holoprojection.

They didn't make it far - half the Death Gliders turned and started shooting them. A few blew up, but others began leaking atmosphere or trailing debris. "They're trying to disable them," Sam reported. "Initiating self-destruction routines."

The disabled pods began to blow up as their communicators broadcasted pre-recorded defiant messages.

"You will never take us alive!"

"Glory to Horde Prime!"

Sam muted them. "Decoy scuttling charges ready."

"Trigger them," Adora ordered.

Sam did. This time, the ship shook as the bombs they had placed in the outer hull went off, simulating a failed scuttling.

She straightened. "Charges detonated as planned."

"Thank you, Sam."

Now, they only had to wait until the Jaffa boarded them. And hope that Apophis's commander didn't decide to just destroy the decoy.

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It was working. The plan was working. Catra clenched her jaws and tried to ignore how her tail was swishing back and forth as she watched the holoprojection showing Apophis's forces close in on the "Steel Fist". The icons for the escape pods were fading out one after another.

She glanced at Melog. Her friend reflected her own mood. Damn. She had to calm down. Even if just waiting for others to act was a pain. No, not the waiting - the hiding in a defenceless decoy.

She had to focus on the situation instead of worrying. "The Death Gliders keep trying to disable the pods even though that only makes them self-destruct when they don't accidentally blow them up," she commented. "Someone's being stubborn."

"If Apophis demanded prisoners - presumably to interrogate about the operation of the weapon - then his chosen commander would rather die than not obey," Teal'c said. "Even if he did all he could and gained the decoy superweapon as ordered, it would still only be a partial success."

But one could argue it was a complete success given the circumstances. Catra was familiar with that situation, though she doubted Apophis would be any more receptive than Shadow Weaver had been.

"Well, without a trained crew to interrogate, Apophis would have some trouble getting it operational," Daniel said. "If it worked at all."

Sha're nodded in agreement. "And if Apophis punishes the commander for this failure, it might cost him one of his most loyal Jaffa."

“First the Palace, then the research station, and now this? Dear old Apophis must be starting to run out of his most loyal commanders,” Jack said with a snort.

“Well, technically, he'll always have a most loyal commander as long as he has commanders, though they might be less competent and even less loyal than their predecessors,” Daniel commented. “But if he selected for loyalty rather than competence, he might end up with more competent commanders if he gets rid of the current ones.”

“I hope we won't end up improving the quality of his officers,” Glimmer said.

“I doubt that.” Sha're shook her head. “Anyone exceptionally competent but of questionable loyalty would have been eliminated by Apophis as soon as he realised it. And any rival commanders would have pointed it out to him at once.”

Catra nodded. She knew exactly how that worked. That was how the Horde had done things. And that was one of the reasons the Goa'uld would lose this war.

On the projection, the Tel'taks and Al'keshs were now surrounding the “Steel Fist” and the debris field that had been the decoy escort. Catra glanced at the camera feeds to check if she could spot them. The scanner feeding the holoprojection would detect far more detail, but she liked using her own eyes. She didn't spot any of them, though - the distance was still too great.

“Alright, folks, prepare to be boarded,” Jack said.

“And hope they don't have better scanners than we thought they have,” Catra added.

“Catra!” Adora hissed.

“You don't have to whisper,” Catra retorted with a grin. “The soundproofing is so good, even I didn’t hear the shooting outside.

We can scream to our heart's content here without anyone hearing us.”

“Catra!” Adora rolled her eyes, but their friends and the two fire teams with them chuckled.

A beep and a red blinking string of letters made Catra snap back to the holoprojection - and curse.

“Additional ships detected!” Sam reported. “Counting… thirty Ha'taks. Fifty Al-Keshs. And forty-two Tel'taks.”

That was a fleet, not just a task force! The holoprojection showed them, coloured yellow, surrounding Apophis's fleet in a pincer movement. The Al'kesh and Tel'taks were already speeding up to engage their counterparts.

Apophis's forces were reacting as well, the faster ships racing to engage the new enemy. But their Al'Keshs and Tel'taks were outnumbered, and the Death Gliders, which might have been able to overwhelm the enemy defences if they had been ready, were not concentrated, many of them just turning away from hunting down escape pods. Catra didn't think they would be able to form up into effective formations before the new fleet had already deployed enough Death Gliders to stop them.

“It looks like Apophis's operational security is even worse than we thought,” Jack commented.

Catra nodded. This must be a rival of Apophis who had found out about this. They had overestimated their enemy. And underestimated another enemy. She cursed. “If his commander thinks that he cannot win this, he might decide to deny them their prize.” In which case he'd order the fleet to shoot at the “Steel Fist”.

She stared at the holoprojection. So far, Apophis's ships were still moving to engage the new arrivals, the screening units launching themselves at the enemy ahead of the Ha'taks. But they were outnumbered two to one. And their formation was split.

“His best chance is to delay the enemy in the hope of taking the “Steel Fist” and escaping with it into hyperspace before the enemy can reach it,” Catra said. That was what she would do. But they had to know that if the “Steel Fist” could flee, she would have already done so - they had disabled the engines, after all, to explain why they hadn't fled before Apophis's forces had arrived. So…

Adora nodded. “It's their best course of action, but they have to know the chances they'll pull it off are low.”

A Tel'tak - cloaked - was headed towards them. But so were two from the new enemy, whoever it was.

“Well, no matter who wins, we'll get to bag a System Lord,” Jack said with fake cheer.

“Unless the other side manages to destroy the decoy to prevent their escape,” Catra retorted with a grim expression. That was the obvious response if you lost the boarding action.

They had to hope that Apophis's forces were either competent enough to get the ship moving before the enemy capital ships were in range, or too incompetent to blow up the ship themselves before the others took it.

Catra didn't like either odds.

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The Double Cross Part 5

Asteroid Belt, Arealis-System, February 20th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Apophis's Tel'tak just docked, sir."

Jack O'Neill nodded at Carter's report. He could see it himself on the screen - a camera was covering the hallway outside the airlock. They didn't have any trouble opening it, of course - the 'boarding team' that had retreated earlier had not bothered to block or seal the airlock; no one would have done that while fleeing. But… "What damage did the 'failing scuttling charges' do to the engines?" he asked.

"They knocked the crystals out of alignment, sir. Exactly as planned." Carter was slightly annoyed; Jack recognised the tone. Probably not really at the implied questioning of her work but their general situation.

The Tel'kats from the unknown System Lord who had decided to crash their party before they could trap Apophis were only a few more minutes away - despite being cloaked from any sensors but the Alliance scanners, they were still avoiding Apophis's ships and Death Gliders, which delayed them.

"Any chance that Apophis's goons will manage to repair the engine in time to escape?" Jack looked at Carter.

"If they have a skilled hyperdrive engine technician with them who immediately starts working…" Carter shook her head. "No chance, sir. We wanted damage that would take long enough to repair to make the boarding team's retreat believable."

"I know," Jack said. "And it was a good decision. No one could have predicted this."

On the screen, the airlock opened, and he could see the Jaffa pouring through the opening. Blowing it open would have been

faster, but that would have led to the ship's air being vented into space if they undocked - or if their ship got shot off the airlock.

The boarders split in two, one heading for the bow part of the ship and one headed towards aft. Or whatever Navy pukes called it. Bridge and engine room. We should build a ship with the important rooms switched, or hidden, he thought. Would confuse the snakes. At least once.

On the holoprojection, the two other Tel'taks were closing in as well, just circling around a damaged Death Glider. Trying to be sneaky snakes.

"They didn't bring bombs," Jack noted aloud. "They can't blow the ship up from the bridge or the engine room, either."

"We know that, but the Jaffa and their masters don't," Daniel said.

Jack understood what he meant - they could trigger the real scuttling charges and hide their smuggling compartments amongst the debris. The snakes would blame each other, with no one the wiser, and keep killing each other.

The victor might stay and collect the wreckage to study, though, if only to have something to show to their master. Still, with the stealth modules, they had good odds of avoiding being noticed until it was safe to recover them. And they had enough supplies and air scrubbers to last a long time. Certainly long enough for a 'Horde task force' to show up and check what had happened to their missing 'superweapon'.

It was the smart decision to take - the mission was fubar. Apophis's goons couldn't get the decoy to their Lord before they were boarded in turn. And odds were, they tried to shoot it up at that point anyway. But…

"So… which System Lord do you think we'll trap instead of Apophis?" Catra asked, flashing her teeth in a cocky grin. Her tail was swishing back and forth quite rapidly, though. And Melog looked not quite as cocky as she did, Jack noted.

“Probably Sokar or Heru’ur,” Glimmer said, nodding calmly. “They are fighting him and would likely have focused their spies on him and have the forces ready to react.”

“I concur,” Sha’re said. “But we cannot exclude the possibility that other System Lords have been closely observing the conflict, waiting for an opportunity to take out one of their rivals - or all three.”

“Yes.” Adora nodded. “We planned for Apophis, but we can adapt and capture someone else.”

Sure, they could. But they had prepared for Apophis and his defences, not anyone else. All their contingencies to extract them would be useless. Odds were, the relief forces assigned to get them out if they had to hunker down and hold out until relieved would be out of position now.

Carter and Daniel were looking at Jack, too. They knew that as well as he did that he really should push to abort the mission right here and now - the other Tel’taks were closing in now. About one more minute, tops. And Apophis’s Jaffa were flailing around on the bridge and the engine room, trying to get weapons working that were carefully disabled beforehand. If they didn’t seal off the hallways, they’d be trying to breathe vacuum as soon as their Tel’tak was in range of the enemy’s guns.

And yet… Jack had mostly joked about bagging another System Lord, but they had put a lot of work into this mission. Work he wouldn’t want to go to waste. Not when they had decent chances to pull off a victory from the jaws of defeat. After all, whoever was attacking Apophis wasn’t expecting this to be a trap either and would be unprepared for them.

And unprepared for She-Ra.

Jack nodded and smiled - about as forcedly as the others, he’d bet. “I think it’s gonna be Sokar. That’s the kind of sneaky move he loves, according to what we know.”

Daniel blinked, and Carter rolled her eyes, but they would follow him.

And the Etherians were already sold on it anyway.

*****

Adora nodded. No matter who won this battle, odds were the decoy would attract a System Lord, and then they could spring their trap. Capture the Goa'uld, take over the ship and escape with it.

"The second boarding force is in range," Sam announced. "They've started their attack run."

"Standard formations," Catra commented as the holoprojection showed the two Tel'taks flying towards the docked one.

"If it works, it works," Jack said.

Moments later, the ship shook, and Adora saw Apophis's Tel'tak shaking as multiple blasts hit it, piercing its hull. She didn't hear anything, though, which was eerie.

Catra pressed her lips together - she must find this disorienting as well, then.

The Tel'tak shook from more hits but remained docked, and Adora couldn't see any secondary explosions. For a moment, she wondered if the Tel'tak would survive this, forcing the attackers to make another run. But then, the ship was ripped apart as something blew up in the aft section, spewing debris into the path of the two attackers, whose shields flared as they flew through the expanding cloud.

And the decoy ship shuddered again when the struck Tel'tak's remains were blown away from the airlock. On the screen, Adora saw a squad of Jaffa taking up positions across the hallway from the airlock.

“They’re trying to use it as a choke point,” Jack said. “That should buy them a bit more time to get the engine working. What do you think, Carter?”

“They’ll need at least a few more minutes,” Sam replied. “They have yet to align any of the crystals.”

Adora glanced at the screen showing the engine room. The Jaffa - fewer than before; some must have gone to defend the airlock - were wrestling a massive crystal into place. Adora wasn’t an expert, but she doubted that would be enough for precision machinery.

“Watch the hull cameras!” Catra suddenly snapped.

Adora turned to look at the other screen, where Sam was quickly enlarging a particular feed. She could see that the Tel’tak had not docked to the airlock, but the hull next to it - and people were leaving the ship.

“That’s not standard armour,” Sam said.

“It is an armoured vacuum suit,” Teal’c said. “Although a rather old-fashioned one.”

“Can you see any symbols to identify who is behind this?” Jack asked.

“The places where such markings are usually placed are clear,” Teal’c replied.

“So… someone’s trying to be extra-sneaky,” Jack commented. “Sounds like Sokar.”

“I agree. Heru’ur is not known for such subterfuge,” Teal’c said.

“Or he has never been caught,” Catra pointed out as the Jaffa in suits opened the airlock.

Was the airlock damaged by the destruction of Apophis's Tel'tak? Or didn't the new attackers want to risk suffering the same fate if they docked? Or…

"It's not closing," Catra said.

Oh. Adora grimaced when the inner door of the airlock opened, and the air inside the hallway shot out into the vacuum, dragging the waiting Jaffa with them. They were still flailing, still alive, when they were sucked into space. One managed to grab the doorframe and stop himself from being thrown clear of the ship, but Adora saw a flash illuminating the airlock's insides, and then the hapless Jaffa, a hole blown through his chest, was floating in space as well. That was a very nasty way to die…

"Yeah, that's a bit too clever for a System Lord who likes fighting in the trenches," Jack commented.

"Hey!" Glimmer protested.

Adora scowled as well. Princesses fought at the front; that was how it was done. Your power didn't serve anyone if you stayed behind the lines.

Catra, of course, chuckled. "What about Generals fighting in the trenches?"

"It's not the same!" Jack retorted. "We're talking snakes here - they generally don't like to risk their lives."

"Any System Lord fighting at the frontline risks getting stabbed in the back as much as he risks death at the hands of his opponents," Sha're added.

"Heru'ur is famous for defying those dangers," Teal'c nodded.

Adora watched the cameras again. The hallway had lost all its air, but the internal doors had held - both the Jaffa on the bridge and in engineering were unaffected. Well, physically - the engineers

were looking frantic as they continued to struggle with the repairs, and the ones on the bridge looked struck.

"They must not have expected that." Catra shook her head. "If they vent the rest of the ship, they'll win this. Apophis boarders didn't bring any spacesuits."

"Must be embarrassing to miss that," Jack said with a scoff and a glance at his own custom spacesuit.

Adora nodded. Boarding actions were dangerous enough; not to prepare for a hull breach was suicide.

Suddenly, the repair crew in the engineering section froze for a moment before stopping their work on the crystals. Instead, they rushed to the reactor controls.

"They're trying to overload the reactor," Sam confirmed Adora's suspicion. "I've countered their orders."

"Good. Can you make it look like a computer glitch or safety protocol?" Jack asked.

"I already did that, sir," Sam replied.

"Ah, of course." Jack looked a bit embarrassed himself.

On the screen, the Jaffa in spacesuits advanced, splitting up as had Apophis's team before - only this one had double their numbers.

Adora didn't think Apophis's forces would win this. But that meant…

"Two Al'keshs have broken off from the fighting and are headed towards us," Sam reported.

"Apophis's commander must have realised he can't win this," Catra said. "Let's hope Sokar's forces are good enough to stop his last attack."

Adora nodded in agreement.

*****

Samantha Carter watched intently as her scanner tracked the two Al'Keshs flying towards the "Steel Fist". Unlike the Death Gliders starting their attack runs, the bombers had enough firepower to destroy the decoy. Usually, bombs were as useless in space combat as they were in a dogfight, but with the ship immobilised, that wasn't an issue. And it didn't take much to compensate for the lack of gravity - a bomb would continue the trajectory of the ship launching it at the moment of separation. Sam had no doubt that Apophis's crews were trained enough to manage that. And if they weren't, they were likely fanatical enough to ram the decoy.

She ran a few calculations in her head. Rough, but sufficient to estimate the effect. If one Al'Kesh rammed the "Steel Fist", the shielded compartments could hold - provided the shields went up in time. Two Al'Keshs made that rather less probable. "We might have to enact the evacuation plan, sir," she said, "if the bombers are on a suicide course." Which they wouldn't know until it would be almost too late to react.

The General leaned forward, tense and focused, and stared at the holoprojection. "The new snakes are moving to stop them."

Sam nodded. The attackers' Death Gliders, which had been fighting their counterparts, were disengaging and swinging around to attack the two Al'Keshs. But she could already tell that the majority wouldn't reach the bombers in time to stop them, and the firepower of those who would was unlikely to be enough.

"The Tel'taks are undocking," Catra reported.

Adding two stealth ships would even up things, but they had to accelerate first to intercept the bombers.

The first Death Gliders, some of Apophis's own in pursuit, were in range now and started firing. The blasts were deflected by the Al'Keshs' shields, though, and by focusing on the bombers, they

left themselves open to the fighters behind them. Sam saw two, then another, explode in short order. No, that wouldn't…

She drew a sharp breath when she realised the surviving Death Gliders weren't pulling up for another attack run but kept accelerating straight at the Al'Keshs. Even though she had considered suicide attacks, to see it happen…

“They're ramming them!” Adora gasped.

A moment later, the first Death Glider hit the shields of the leading bomber and blew up, followed by another. The shields shattered with the third, and the Al'Kesh suddenly changed course in an obvious attempt to evade the next.

They were too late, though - two Death Gliders crashed into the ship at near-full speed, still firing, and sent it reeling. No secondary explosions, but the ship was blown off-course, trailing debris.

“Fanatics,” the General muttered as more Death Gliders went in, all firing until they crashed into the bomber.

Sam quickly zoomed in on the struck ship. The hull had buckled under the impacts, she could see multiple breaches, and… there was the first secondary explosion. Not a magazine, but… The ship vanished in a ball of fire before she could finish her thought.

“They were ordered to stop the bombers at all costs,” Teal'c commented. “And they did.”

The second bomber, trailing the first, had managed to change course in time and had only been hit by two suicide attacks. But that manoeuvre had brought it right into the path of the two Tel'taks. Still cloaked, both flew straight at it.

Sam winced at the explosion that followed.

She felt the deck under her feet shake slightly - the surviving Death Gliders of Apophis's force were throwing themselves at the

decoy, but even with their counterparts' numbers reduced by those who had intercepted the Al'Keshs, there were enough Death Gliders around to make that tactic much less effective. And the "Steel Fist" was much tougher than an Al'Kesh. Only two more Death Gliders managed to ram the ship before they were all destroyed, and the damage done was minimal, according to Sam's scanner.

Sam checked the state of the main battle. Apophis's forces were collapsing. Half of his Ha'taks had been destroyed, and the remaining ones were under withering fire as they tried to disengage and retreat - not they were trying to reach the decoy, she realised.

"Won't make it," Catra commented. "Too slow, and the attackers can concentrate their fire."

Sam agreed with the assessment.

"Look, they've reached the engine room," Sha're called out. "They are…"

"...about to blow the doors," the General finished for her with a grim expression.

Without having sealed off the hole in the hull. Sam winced - Apophis's Jaffa were helpless. They couldn't even launch an attack of their own; opening the doors would only speed up their deaths, and… Her eyes widened - the defenders were moving to the doors. Some were tying themselves to the consoles closest to the doors. Why would…? "They're about to open the doors themselves!" she blurted out.

The General cursed. Catra also cursed.

The doors slid open, and the surprised attackers still placing charges were cut down by the defenders' staff weapons and zat'nik'tels. One of them cut himself off, Sam saw, trying to grab a charge as he was sucked out of the room, but his hands missed. Two staff blasts killed him moments later.

The defenders switched their fire to the remaining attackers. Sam saw one of them get hit, his suit rupturing, as they shot back. But the outcome was never in doubt - not when the defenders were already suffocating.

But they kept shooting until they fell unconscious. By the time the last one died, one of the attackers shooting him with a zat'nik'tel when he collapsed, the bridge was under attack as well.

Sam already knew how that would end.

*****

The waiting was the worst, but they didn't have a choice any more. Catra scoffed under her breath as she watched the holoprojection. After finishing off Apophis's forces, which had died to a man trying to destroy the “Steel Fist”, the new fleet had formed up in a defensive formation around the decoy ship while throwing over a hundred workers at the task of restoring the ship's hyperdrive before either the Horde or Apophis came back with more ships to retake the decoy ship.

And most of those workers were humans - slaves. Catra had already seen Jaffa literally using whips to drive them to work harder. That meant that if Catra and her friends tried to escape by triggering the scuttling charges, blowing the decoy ship up and escaping while cloaked (and disguised as debris as a backup), they would be killing over a hundred helpless people in addition to a bunch of fanatical Jaffa. They couldn't do that.

Not that Catra would give them good odds of escaping even if they did that, not between all the Death Gliders flitting around the “Steel Fist”, probably hunting for more suicidal cloaked Tel'taks. No, they were now committed to the plan; the window to call it off and withdraw had closed.

But it meant she had nothing to do but wait for the workers to finish fixing the hyperdrive and hope nothing else would go wrong. Like a third System Lord sending forces to take the

superweapon. Or Apophis returning with more ships. Or the Asgard arriving to ‘stop the Horde’ or whatever.

She snorted. Any of those scenarios were unlikely. If Apophis had more ships, he would have sent them in the first place. The Asgard didn’t have the ships to spare and didn't really care about the Horde or Earth - not enough to get involved. And the odds of them knowing about this were slim to none. And if a third System Lord not only had gotten the fake intel about this operation but had the forces ready to move in time to stop Apophis, then Apophis's security was so bad, he should have been defeated by his rivals already.

Catra knew all that, but a little bit of worry remained. Apophis's security had been been broken by one rival already, after all. Which reminded her… “Hey, Teal'c - seen anything to identify the new guys yet?”

Teal'c replied without looking away from the screen he used to watch the engine room, where most workers were slaving away. “Not so far. Not even the slaves are carrying symbols of worship of their fake god. That in itself is telling - whoever is behind this is quite skilled at hiding their involvement. They must have experience with hiding their operations.”

Ah! Catra's eyes widened for a moment. That sounded like…

“Like, say, having fooled everyone into thinking they were dead for a thousand years, like Sokar?” Jack beat Catra to the punch.

“I believe he would be the most likely suspect, as the saying goes,” Teal'c said. “We know he was already fighting Apophis, so he would have had forces in the area ready to be deployed, and even after the purges following Apophis's setbacks, it is not unreasonable to assume that Sokar has some spies left at his rival's court.”

Catra nodded. That sounded plausible.

“Sokar…” Sha're trailed off, and Catra saw her take a deep breath. “His reputation for cruelty is only rivalled by Ba’al's.”

“Well, taking him out will be a good thing, then,” Jack commented. “Not that taking out a snake is ever a bad thing, of course.”

Catra agreed with that as well, though the Alliance didn't know as much about Sokar's realm as they knew about Apophis's, so exploiting the loss of its ruler would be more difficult.

“We might even discover at least one of Sokar's hidden worlds,” Sam added.

“Indeed,” Teal'c agreed. “It is unlikely that he will have the decoy moved to his capital, if only to keep it secret from his own court, but with what little is known about his territory, any new information will be a boon.”

“That will make it harder to escape, though,” Bow pointed out. “We won't know the area, and we won't have any allies nearby. Not close enough, at least, or the spy bot network would have found the system already.”

“If we manage to capture Sokar, this will decapitate his forces and throw his court into chaos,” Sha're retorted. “His underlings will start struggling for power at once. Sokar’s rule relies on fear above all else.”

“And no one fears the chump who gets captured in his own realm by a few good men and women. And cats,” Jack said, nodding at Catra and Melog with a grin.

She snorted at that. It made sense, but it was also more than a little optimistic. “Let's not get overconfident. We have to capture him first.” And then escape before Sokar's underlings realised that this was the best opportunity to get rid of their boss. “And for that, those idiots need to finish repairing the hyperdrive.”

“The crystals we knocked out of alignment were further disrupted by the fighting between Apophis's forces and the new attackers,” Sam said. She sounded a bit defensive, as if it was her fault that the Goa'uld were incompetent. “The attacks by the Death Gliders also damaged one of the projectors, which will require further repairs.”

“Any estimate for how long that will take them?” Jack asked.

Sam grimaced. “Based on their performance so far, at least several hours.”

Catra shook her head. Motivation by whipping didn't work. Especially not when it came to difficult tasks such as repairing high-tech machinery. People made mistakes under such stress. And speaking of mistakes… “Can you check their work?” she asked.

“We are plugged into the ship’s systems and can run a diagnosis,” Sam replied.

“Good. I'd hate for this mission to get derailed further by a faulty hyperdrive sending us god knows where,” Jack said. “I'm already behind on the latest season of the Simpsons.”

Catra snorted, but Bow perked up. “Oh, you are?” he asked. “I’ve got all episodes that were aired so far on my tablet.”

“Really?” Jack looked surprised.

Probably hasn't expected his joke to be taken seriously, Catra thought with a snicker.

“Yes.” Bow smiled, then looked embarrassed. “My brothers like them, and, well…” he shrugged. “Everyone's still doing it.”

“Well, can I borrow your tablet then?” Jack asked.

“Jack! Are you seriously going to watch a cartoon series in the middle of the mission?” Daniel blurted out.

“Do we have anything else to do?”

Daniel blinked but didn’t seem to have an answer to that.

Neither did Sam, though she was frowning, Catra noticed.

So, it seemed as if they would indeed watch cartoons in the middle of a mission. Well, Jack would, at least. But there weren't many alternatives. Of course, Catra could think of a number of things to do with Adora that beat watching cartoons, but they lacked the privacy for that.

Quite the dilemma. Catra blamed the Goa'uld for that.

*****

The Simpsons had been funnier in the past, in Jack O'Neill's opinion. And he blamed the Etherians for it - the ‘Princess of Springfield’ character, an exiled Etherian, had started with the ‘magic goes wrong’ episodes, which now seemed to take up half the season. If it wasn’t Bart getting cursed, Lisa trying out witchcraft, or Homer annoying ancient ghosts by mistake, you could bet on some Etherian guest character appearing and making a mess with magic.

Far too much magic in the Simpsons, for Jack's taste. He shook his head as the current episode ended with half the town turned into the Simpson's version of the Whispering Woods - for the second time this season.

“Whoever is writing those episodes has no idea about Etherian magic,” Glimmer commented. “Even for a cartoon show, I'd expect more research.”

“But they hit the nail on the head with the exiled princess Sour Wasp,” Catra retorted with a grin. “I wonder if Sweet Bee will sue.”

Jack chuckled at the thought. He'd still prefer it if the character were removed.

“Ah, Bow,” Daniel spoke up, “do your brothers prefer the new seasons or the old ones? I mean, the seasons released before Etheria made contact with Earth or the ones after that point?”

“Both,” Bow replied. “Though they don't get all the jokes in the older ones. And half the jokes about Etheria are funny because they are so wrong.”

“Ah. I was wondering about their grasp of the cultural context.” Daniel nodded.

“I don't get many of the nuances of the jokes in Earth media either,” Sha're added.

“You're making a lot of progress,” Daniel told her. “It's not as if it's different for the audience on Earth outside the USA.”

“That's because you have as many people on your world as the rest of the galaxy put together,” Glimmer grumbled.

“It's not quite as extreme,” Daniel corrected her. “Though we do have a lot of distinct cultures.”

“Well, on Etheria, most are only getting to know Western media,” Bow said.

“And some Japanese,” Catra added with a sigh.

“If your impression of Earth culture is based on our media, it might have interesting effects on cross-cultural relationships,” Daniel said. “I’ve mentioned that in a paper for the tourism commission.”

Glimmer groaned. “Don't remind me about them. They don't get that the Stargate is not a tourist transport.”

“Or that our cruisers aren’t cruise ships,” Jack added with a snort.

“We don't have any cruisers, sir,” Carter cut in.

Jack rolled his eyes at her. He knew that, but his quip wouldn't have worked as well with frigates. “The point is that we don’t have the spare transportation capacity to dedicate to tourists. Or the resources to waste on protecting interstellar Spring Breakers and Snow Birds.”

“Well, I don’t think that the commission expects mass tourism to take off anytime soon. But they are hoping for luxury trips, as far as I understand,” Daniel said.

Jack snorted again. Of course, it was about luxury trips for the rich - they had the contacts and influence amongst politicians to prop up the commission in the first place. Same for the pressure to sell shuttles to civilians. Some people really didn’t get that a shuttle wasn’t a Humvee.

“If anyone wants to travel to other planets, they can join up,” Campbell commented. Isa and the rest of the two fire teams in the compartment voiced their agreement. “They'll get all the exciting travel they can stomach.”

Jack doubted that if the kind of people who wanted to go on luxury trips joined the Alliance forces, they would end up on the frontlines. They tended to go for cushy jobs in the rear. Preferably in some exotic travel destination. At least he hadn't had to deal with them at Stargate Command, thanks to the secrecy, and he didn't have to deal with them in the Alliance thanks to his position. Some perks that came with a general's rank were nicer than others.

“So, what about the next episode?” Bow asked, holding up his tablet.

Jack looked around. No one seemed terribly enthusiastic. Bow was probably just politely asking, Catra was curled up in Adora's lap in a way that would have half the brass Jack knew scream about inappropriate PDAs, Glimmer was looking bored, Carter hadn't watched the cartoons anyway but had been busy with her computer and Teal'c was… Teal'c. Daniel and Sha're looked

interested, at least, and Jack's people in the back were a toss-up between watching and sleeping.

“Maybe we should…” he began.

“Sir! They brought the hyperdrive online,” Carter interrupted him. “The “Steel Fist” is now operational.”

Jack jumped up and walked over to her. “That was fast, wasn’t it?”

“It's within expected parameters,” Carter replied. Which probably meant she could have done it faster by herself.

Jack checked the feeds from the hidden cameras. The workers were exhausted - some had collapsed in the engine room - but the bridge crew was busy. Very busy. And on the holoprojection, the patrolling Death Gliders were racing back towards the Ha'taks.

“Get ready, folks,” he called out. “Looks like we'll be on the way to wherever soon.”

*****

Hyperspace, February 20th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“According to the navigational data from the ship’s computers, we’re on the way to PT-1853. The Jaffa have plotted the course in several legs.”

Adora nodded at Sam’s report. “Do we have any data on that system?”

“Except for the fact that it has a Stargate, no. Exploration has been cut short due to the war effort, and the Tok’ra’s data - at least the data they shared - has nothing on it either,” Sam replied.

That meant none of the Goa’uld knew about the system. None but the System Lord behind the attack on Apophis’s forces. That didn’t mean it had to be Sokar - not many Goa’uld would send a

captured superweapon to one of their main systems - but it made it a bit more likely; no one knew much about his territory.

"Good work, Carter. Let's hope that the Jaffa don't find our taps."

"Unless they physically dismantle the entire computer system and manage to spot the data ports we've hidden inside, that is unlikely, sir." Sam sounded a bit annoyed. "We're using the ship's own systems, after all, which they control, and our access is purely passive."

Sam was right, of course - they had done everything to prevent their deception from being discovered. Their plan wasn't perfect, of course - the fact that they were not on the way to Apophis proved that better than anything else.

"We're dealing with a paranoid snake expecting traitors everywhere - who has just pulled off an intel coup against Apophis," Jack pointed out.

"We built the system with this in mind and implemented the Tok'ra's advice."

Jack grumbled something Adora didn't catch but which made Catra snort. "I don't think the snake in charge of this will have the ship's systems dismantled for inspection," she said. They would want to keep the 'superweapon' ready to be used as soon as possible - before Apophis might decide to spread the news of this to alert all other System Lords of the danger and unite them against this."

"And they probably don't expect such treachery from the Horde," Bow added.

"Unless they know about his mind control chips," Glimmer retorted.

"Horde Prime probably kept those secret so his enemies wouldn't be warned," Catra pointed out. "Makes it easier to appear all-powerful and all-knowing, too, if people don't know your tricks."

Adora reached out and pulled Catra closer; her love must be remembering her time under Horde Prime's control. Cata grumbled a bit but didn't wriggle out of her embrace.

"At the very least, they won't try to pull the systems apart while they are travelling," Sam said.

"Never underestimate their fanaticism," Jack objected.

"They will not risk destroying the prize they were sent out to secure for their false god," Teal'c said. "Nor will they start to dismantle it without explicit orders. And such orders will likely be given in person - no System Lord will trust an underling with the power to destroy them."

Adora nodded. That was what they were counting on. "How long will we travel?" she asked.

Sam hit a few keys. "If they follow the plotted course, we'll be in hyperspace, with a few interruptions for navigation, for a week."

Adora frowned. They had laid the trap near Apophis's territory. "So, they took a task force standing by to attack Apophis and sent them to intercept us, and now they're withdrawing to a more distant base."

"Probably a forward base for attacks against Apophis," Jack added. "Let's hope our snake will want to check the goods before sending us deeper into their territory."

Adora nodded in agreement. She didn't want to spend weeks or months in hyperspace. That hadn't been a concern when they were planning to trick Apophis.

"So… since we'll be a while here…" Jack grinned. "What's next on the menu as entertainment?"

*****

PT-1853 System, February 27th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“We're about to exit hyperspace.”

Adora suppressed a sigh of relief at the announcement. After a week in hyperspace, she'd even prefer dropping into an ambush to spending another night in the stealth compartment. Sure, they had everything to survive for months if needed, but for one thing: Privacy.

All she wanted was to capture the Goa'uld responsible for extending their trip, head to the closest Stargate and return home to lock herself and Catra in their room for the next twenty-four hours or so. And if she had to personally beat the Goa'uld's entire guard for that, she'd do it happily - another week of this, and she'd agree with Catra about using the shower here! Though Melog, who was mirroring Catra's emotions, would probably claw a hole through the walls before that, if Catra didn't do it herself.

“Great! I am sick of Earth TV marathons!” Glimmer sounded as frustrated as Adora felt.

“We also have literally millions of books with us.” Daniel obviously didn’t quite get what Glimmer was really frustrated about.

Adora saw Sha're lean over to whisper in his ear, followed by Daniel blushing. Well, he understood now.

“Exiting hyperspace in five, four…”

Adora raised her chin and braced for the familiar feeling.

“..three, two, one…”

And they left hyperspace. Adora watched the holoprojection change as their magitech scanner switched on.

They were inside a system with two planets. And a couple of asteroids - no ring, though.

A moment later, several dozen Ha'taks and even more smaller ships appeared in the projection.

“That's either a major fleet base, or whoever is in command doesn't even trust their chosen task force to stay loyal,” Jack commented.

“No System Lord trusts anyone,” Sha're said.

“They've opened communications,” Sam announced.

On the screen that had been showing shows and movies for a week straight, a Jaffa appeared. Adora recognised him - it was the Jaffa in charge of the task force. Gun'il, as they had found out from overhearing chatter amongst the crew.

The picture of him shrank to show another Jaffa, and Adora winced at the sight of the burn scars that covered the man's face. *“Gun’il. You have achieved what you were ordered to do?”*

“Yes, Kal'toc. We have secured the weapon Apophis craved and slaughtered his warriors. Our God's will was done.”

“That remains for Him to judge,” Kal'toc retorted. *“Prepare for His arrival.”*

Gun'il bowed his head, and even on the screen, you could see that he was tense before the connection was cut.

“They don't mention their System Lord's name,” Daniel commented. “I thought this might merely be an excessive interpretation of an order not to reveal their origin, but they do it even here, in a supposedly secure system. This is quite peculiar.”

“That's not normal,” Sha're agreed.

“Yeah. Usually, you can’t stop them from praising their god,” Jack said.

“Indeed.”

“And the only System Lord we know who we don't know much about is Sokar.” Catra shrugged. “Another clue that it's him, but

we already pretty much knew that.”

“Such religious practices can give us valuable insight into a System Lord's domain,” Daniel objected. “If saying their god's name is taboo, then that could tell us something about their faith. Such a practice is not very common on Earth.”

“Or all of them are just afraid of attracting his attention by saying his name,” Jack said. “We'll know soon enough,” he added, pointing at a Ha'tak that was leaving the planet's orbit and headed, together with most of the fleet, to their position. “I bet he just arrived by Stargate and ring transporter.”

*****

“They've docked,” Sam announced, even though everyone could see the airlock on the screen.

Adora clenched and unclenched her fingers, almost summoning her sword. Finally! Their target had arrived.

Gun'il and his guards were lined up facing the airlock, more nervous than Adora had ever seen them, even though they clearly had achieved their mission. Then the doors slid back, revealing a Goa'uld, and the Jaffa dropped to their knees.

“Sokar,” both Sha're and Teal’c said together when they saw him.

“Told you,” Catra added. She was sheathing and unsheathing her claws, Adora saw. And her tail and ears were twitching.

“Do you recognise him?” Daniel asked.

“We recognise his symbol,” Sha're replied. “Not his host. It's been a thousand years since he was seen by other System Lords.”

The Jaffa were calling him their lord, praising him frantically, until he allowed them to stand up.

“Someone's really full of it,” Jack commented as the Goa'uld started his inspection of the ship, led by the still-tense Gun'il.

Adora clenched her teeth. The Jaffa had won a victory for their god - or so they thought, at least. How cruel was this Goa'uld to make his most loyal followers fear him so?

She summoned her sword and went to the concealed doors that led into the control room of the ‘Core Cracking Cannon’. Soon, he wouldn't be able to terrify people any more.

“There he comes!” Jack whispered from behind. “He just entered the room.”

Adora glanced at the screen behind her, checked again where the Jaffa stood, then used the door controls.

She burst through the opening a moment later, sword turned shield, but the Jaffa guards were just reacting to the ambush, and Adora reached Sokar before they could even try to stop her. She smashed him into the warriors behind him, a personal shield flaring up, then breaking around him as all went down in a tangle of limbs and armour. A moment later, Catra jumped past her to rake her claws over the closest warrior.

“How dare you!” Sokar bellowed, raising his arm - with a Goa'uld torture device! “You will…!”

While shots rang out behind her and bullets and staff weapon fire cut down the guards on the side, Adora smashed the Goa'uld over the head with the flat side of her sword, knocking him out. Catra took care of the closest guards with a bit more vehemence than usual.

“Room secure!” Isa bellowed as the last guard went down.

Jack nodded. “Alright. Move to the bridge! We need to…”

The ship shuddered, almost sending them stumbling, and Adora heard the sounds of explosions. “We're under fire!” she snapped.

"The escorts have disabled our engines," Adora heard Sam report over the communicator.

Jack cursed. "They're very quick to stab their god in the back. Too quick."

Adora nodded. This didn't look like a coup.

"More Tel'taks are on the way," Sam told them.

Boarders.

Catra looked at their prisoner. "Let's hope we did get the right snake."

If this wasn't Sokar… Well, no matter what, they had to secure the ship and repel the boarders.

And then find a way to get away.

*****

The Double Cross Part 6

PT-1853 System, February 27th, 2000 (Earth Time)

They were surrounded by dozens of Ha'taks and their escorts, commanded by one of the worst Goa'uld they knew of, and the enemy had just disabled their engines.

Samantha Carter had been in worse situations, but not many.

She checked the readings from the Steel Fist's systems on her computer. The Goa'uld had destroyed the sublight engines, but the hyperdrive was still functional. Although it relied on power from the main reactor, and the readings she got from the engine room weren't good.

Sam switched through a few windows and frowned. The reactor output was fluctuating - the engines' destruction must have damaged it, likely through a power surge. She clenched her teeth. That wouldn't have happened if they had used the latest Horde technology, but the Alliance had been worried about that falling into the hands of the Goa'uld even if the ship was scuttled, and so they had used designs that the Goa'uld already knew. Inferior designs. But the damage seemed repairable - though it would take some time. And even if they could open a subspace window, they still needed some form of propulsion to push the ship through it before the Goa'uld destroyed them. Although…

"Bridge secured. What are the snakes doing?" The General's voice came over the comms.

Sam checked the holoprojection. "Holding their positions, sir."

"Can we get away?" Adora asked.

"We need the reactor repaired and a way to accelerate the ship for a short period," Sam replied. "Then we can escape into hyperspace."

"How long will that take?"

"It depends on how fast we can repair the reactor and rig up a directed explosive to propel the ship," Sam replied.

"I like that plan," the General said. She had known it would appeal to him.

"Bow, Sam - get started on it," Adora ordered. *"Have the Goa'uld tried to contact us yet?"*

Sam didn't know if that question was aimed at her, but she checked her data anyway as she got up. "No contact yet," she said. "I'm moving to the reactor room."

"I'm headed there as well," Bow added.

Why haven't they contacted us yet? Sam wondered as she ran past a dozen dead Jaffa. They had disabled the ship's engines as soon as Adora had taken the Goa'uld captive, so what were the Jaffa waiting for? Or were they waiting for someone? What if they hadn't captured Sokar, but another Goa'uld serving him? Maybe as a decoy?

She clenched her teeth. She couldn't worry about that - she had to focus on repairing the reactor and setting an explosive charge powerful enough to accelerate the ship forward without destroying it.

She would have to trust that the others could handle the rest.

*****

Catra had been in worse situations than being stuck in a crippled ship surrounded by enemies, but that wasn't a high bar to clear given her experiences.

"Should we call them and tell them we have a hostage?" Daniel asked.

Before Cara could tell him how bad that was, Sha're spoke up: "No. If this is a coup attempt, or a plot by a rival, that might push them to destroy the ship to ensure Sokar is dead. And if this isn't a coup, we would give them information without gaining anything in return."

"Yep." Jack nodded. "If they realise that this was a trap all along, they might just blow us up. As long as they think this is a superweapon, they might still be wary."

"If they think this is a working superweapon, why haven't they boarded us?" Glimmer retorted. "Aren't they afraid that we'll blow them away?"

"They have us surrounded, and our shields are down." Catra pointed at the radar display. "If we powered up a weapon, they'd notice and blow us up." And even if the superweapon were real, they wouldn't be able to kill the entire fleet in one volley - the Goa'uld had had a week to study the fake schematics and documentation, and they knew how it supposedly worked. They might fear a self-destruct that wrecked the entire area, but those were fanatically loyal Jaffa, so who knew how they would react to such a threat?

"Even if it were a coup, they would want to make sure Sokar is dead, so they should have been calling us," Jack said. "Maybe pretending to be loyal to him or something." He shook his head. "I don't think our guy is Sokar."

"You think they're waiting for the real Sokar to arrive and handle this?" Catra cocked her head.

Daniel frowned. "Wouldn't he have ordered them to secure the ship before that?"

"If he thinks it could be a trap, he might expect that to trigger it again," Catra replied.

"He has a reputation for twisted plots," Sha're said. "But this could still be a coup - or a plot by a rival, like Ba'al. If they had to

improvise, they might still be trying to take control of the fleet surrounding us."

"I'd expect them to have started shooting each other in that case," Jack commented.

"Not if the rest of the fleet doesn't know about it," Sha're retorted. "But you're right - we should see some signs of internal fighting soon in that case. It's unlikely that a coup or a rival's sabotage would work perfectly."

"As we just proved," Jack said. "Carter? Any update?"

"We're working on the reactor, but it will take a while yet - we're still assessing the damage and need to recalibrate the controls, sir."

That wasn't good. Maybe they should have taken Entrapta and Hordak with them… But if everything went wrong here, those two would be needed more than ever.

"If this doesn't work, what are our chances if we retreat into the stealth compartment and scuttle the ship as we originally planned?" Daniel asked with a glance to Sha're.

"I think whoever is in charge of the enemy here will collect every single last speck of dust left behind," Catra told her. That was what she would do in their place. "We might escape with the stealth field active, but if we're unlucky, someone could spot stuff hitting us or disappearing in the stealth field, and then they'll have us. And even if it worked, we'd still be drifting in space - and no one's coming to our rescue here since no one knows we're here." They were out of range of the Spy bot network, so they couldn't even call for help.

"Well, I guess it's do or die then," Jack said. "Let's hope the snakes wait a bit longer to sort out what they want to do."

A moment later, the console behind him lit up with an incoming communication.

Catra glared at him.

*****

There were times when Jack O'Neill was sure that the universe was out to get him. Like, this time right now. He turned to glare at the communication console. Teach him to dare Murphy. He cleared his throat. "Well, let's not make our dear caller wait."

"But you said…" Daniel started to say something, probably about Jack's earlier comment, but trailed off when Jack accepted the call.

A man - a Goa'uld, his eyes were glowing - appeared on the screen in the centre of the bridge. He was sneering, his skin was unnaturally pale, almost as pale as a clone, and Jack could see some veins crisscrossing his bald skull. Compared to the other snakes Jack had seen, this one looked downright alien.

"Colonel O'Neill." And there was the snake voice as well. *"Of course, it would be you. Your reputation precedes you."*

"Actually, it's 'General O'Neill now," Jack replied. Sokar - if that was Sokar - must have used old intel. How that kind of information spread might be useful to find out.

The snake scoffed. *"You have been an annoyance for Apophis."*

Jack smiled. Genuinely - he was proud of that, and if the snake wanted to make some small talk about other System Lords, that meant more time for Carter and Bow to fix the reactor. "Well, he didn't really make it hard."

The Goa'uld's laugh sounded like he was coughing, and his lips twisted into a sneer. *"That made you complacent."* The snake flashed his teeth again. *"Your last mission failed."*

Jack shrugged as nonchalantly as he could. He had to keep the Goa'uld talking so they could get away. "Really? Looks to me as if

both Apophis and the Horde failed. Neither of them is in control of this superweapon. Mission accomplished."

He tensed up. If the snake had seen through their deception, then this was the point where he would gloat. Probably.

"Your 'superweapon' is crippled and surrounded by my fleet, O'Neill."

"So you say." Jack bared his teeth. "But we still control it. And we can destroy it."

"Only at the cost of your own lives."

Had the snake's smile slipped for a moment? Was that the reason why he hadn't sent his Jaffa to board them already? That would mean he didn't know this was a decoy and thought the superweapon was real… Jack shrugged again. "A small price to pay for saving Earth from it. And, well… you've got a kinda reputation. Dying seems preferable to getting captured by you."

The Goa'uld laughed again, slightly longer. And creepier. Jack felt himself shudder when the snake suddenly stopped and stared at him. *"Commendable. But you have not done so yet. I wonder why…"*

Jack resisted the urge to wet his lips. He just had to keep the snake talking. Long enough for Carter and Bow to fix the damn reactor. "You haven't sent in your warriors yet."

"You still have hope of escaping your fate?"

"We're hard to kill. If I had a nickel for every time Apophis thought he had us dead by rights…" Jack grinned.

The Goa'uld frowned for a moment, then matched his grin. *"I am not Apophis. I will not make his mistakes."*

"You're Sokar." Jack nodded.

"Did you hope to take me hostage?" Sokar - if that was really Sokar - snorted. *"I am not as foolish as Apophis."*

"The thought has crossed my mind," Jack told him. He wanted to check back with Carter and get an update, but that would give the game away.

"Another failure of yours, General O'Neill." Sokar slowly shook his head. *"You would have had better chances to escape if you had taken over the ship before arriving here. In fact, given how quickly you took control of the ship, I wonder why you didn't do so - you had ample time for it during the trip."*

Jack clenched his teeth. Sokar was getting close to unravelling everything. Or had he guessed the truth already and was playing with them? He licked his dry lips. "As much as we make it look easy, we still have to prepare for taking over a superweapon."

"And for ambushing a god."

Jack spread his hands. "Can't fault us for trying."

"Oh, I can - and will. Daring to strike at a god deserves a punishment equal to the crime." Sokar chuckled again. *"Did you get greedy? Did you decide that in addition to capturing a superweapon, you would capture a System Lord as well?"*

Jack grimaced. That would have been stupid. But it would explain why they hadn't bailed before.

"And how did you manage to hide from my warriors for so long? I did not send fools on this mission. They knew that their lives would be forfeit if they were fooled by you."

"Wouldn't you like to know?" Jack smiled broadly at the snake. Let him worry about what they had done here to hide. If Sokar was as paranoid as the rest of his peers, he'd make up threats even Jack wouldn't think of.

"I would - and I will. And do you know why, O'Neill?"

"I guess you're dying to tell me why," Jack said.

"Your situation is hopeless. Even if a fleet arrived to save you, my ships would destroy you before they could rescue you. A fate worse than death awaits you - eternal agony for your defiance. And you know all that. And yet, you hope. You don't want to die. You don't want to kill yourself and your men. And that is your fatal weakness."

Jack narrowed his eyes. That sounded very confident. Had he overlooked something? Were they missing a crucial threat? "You want this superweapon. You don't want us to destroy it."

"Correct. But I would rather destroy it than let someone else control it - and use it against me."

Ah. Jack nodded. "You wouldn't be content with our solemn promise not to use it against you, I guess."

Sokar laughed again. *"I have studied you, General. You are no fool. You would not keep such a promise."*

That sounded like a compliment. But coming from a snake, that was an insult. "Worth a try." What was Sokar planning? Was this just a sick way to keep them hoping right until the end? Or did Sokar have a way to get the ship before they could blow it up? If there were any cloaked Tel'taks on the way, their scanner would have detected it.

What was he planning? Jack blinked. And why was the snake's picture getting blurry? He shook his head and almost swayed. Wait…

He glanced to the side. Daniel had taken off his glasses and was blinking rapidly. And Glimmer looked like she was about to fall asleep. Even Teal'c seemed a bit off…

Jack gasped.

"Poison!" he hissed.

*****

Poison? Adora looked around and gasped - her friends were reeling, and she had been so focused on Sokar that she had missed it! “Catra!”

Her love was blinking and frowning, her ears twitching. “I'm…”

Adora summoned her sword and healed her.

“...OK.” Catra finished. “But the others…”

“The poison is already working! If you want to survive, you have to…” Sokar was cut off when the screen blacked out.

“Bastard must have poisoned the fall guy!” Jack muttered.

Adora quickly healed him, then the others - Daniel and Sha're had already collapsed, and some of the soldiers with them weren't looking any better.

“Thank you,” Campbell said.

“Thank you,” Isa added, even though the Socrpionwoman hadn't really seemed affected that much.

“Thanks… Carter!” Jack snapped.

“We're about to finish repairs, sir.” Sam sounded fine.

“Bow?” Glimmer asked.

“Since we were working near the engines and at the reactor, we never removed the space suits,” Bow replied.

Adora sighed with relief. She had managed to heal everyone, and they would soon leave this place.

“Sokar's sending in cloaked Tel'taks!” Catra hissed. “And he's trying to contact us again.”

“Probably to gloat.” Jack scoffed. “And to offer us the antidote in exchange for the weapon.”

“After he told us we'd suffer for eternity?” Adora shook her head.

“Technically, he told Jack that,” Daniel said. He took a deep breath, closing his eyes for a moment.

“Still a bad plan,” Catra said without taking her eyes off the screen showing Sokar's ships approaching them.

“Sokar probably had the underling who visited carrying poison to spoil any assassination attempt.” Sha're, too, took a few deep breaths. “I think that might be standard practice for him, and he just exploited the opportunity here.”

“Sounds like it'd fit Sokar, yeah. And he'll claim it was all planned.” Jack nodded. “How much longer, Carter? We're about to have visitors!”

“We're placing the charges - one more minute, sir!”

“We don't want to start the reactor until the last moment,” Bow added.

That made sense, of course.

“Might not have a minute,” Catra said. “They're about to dock at the lower airlocks - closest to the engine rooms.”

“Prepare to repel boarders!” Jack ordered the soldiers and started to move towards the door leading off the bridge. “Damn, I sound like a Navy puke! And suit up!”

Adora was already running, easily passing him and the others. “I’m covering the starboard airlock!” she snapped.

“They're docking now. I’ve sealed the airlocks, but that won't stop them for long,” Catra replied on the channel. *“I'll join you!”*

Adora knew better than to tell her love to stay back. She reached the starboard lower airlock and took up a position opposite it.

A moment later, Catra, suited up, took the corner behind her, running on all fours - and along the wall for a second. Behind her, the blast doors snapped shut, isolating the compartment.

"Smith! Suit up, damn it - they'll blow the doors again! Isa, Campbell - cover that door. Everyone else, fallback positions one blast door back!" Jack bellowed over the communicator.

"Propulsion charges have been set," Sam reported. *"We're moving to start up the reactor and hyperdrive."*

"Let's hope Sokar won't have the ship blown up once he detects the reactor powering up," Catra whispered.

Adora bit her lower lip and nodded.

Then the airlocks were blown open, and Adora changed her sword to a shield as she let the air drag her forward. As soon as she reached the remains of the door, she grabbed the edge and swung around, entering the Tel'tak with her shield up. She caught two shots on it, another bounced off on her back, and then she started tearing into and through the Jaffa assembled inside the small craft, Catra at her side.

Half a minute later, it was over. The last Jaffa, his suit slashed open by Catra after Adora had torn his weapon away, was still trying to reach her with his arms, but a kick from Catra sent him outside the ship.

"Watch out for grenades! Isa, keep it up!"

The other battle wasn't going as well, but they didn't seem to be losing.

"Reactor starting up!" Sam announced.

"Hyperdrive on standby!" Bow added.

Adora grabbed Catra and hurried back into the ship. The Tel'tak was docked, but better safe than sorry.

They had barely made it inside the wrecked airlock when the ship shook again.

"We've entered hyperspace."

Adora sighed with relief. They were safe - for the moment, at least. But safe enough. Now, all they had to do was to find the closest Stargate and get home. If one of the Two Tel'taks had survived the transition into hyperspace, they could just take it and be gone long before anyone might find the wreckage of the decoy, and…

"Daniel collapsed!" Sha're yelled through the communicator. *"The poison's still active!"*

What? But Adora had healed him - she had healed everyone!

"Man down!" Jack reported.

"I don't feel so well either, sir," Campbell said.

What was going on?

*****

Hyperspace, February 27th, 2000 (Earth Time)

They only had a few minutes - the way they had set things up, the Steel Fist couldn't travel too far through hyperspace. Just enough to get away, to travel far enough so Sokar's fleet would have to search an area too large to find them quickly or easily. Samantha Carter should be preparing the next trip through hyperspace - calculating the course, checking the drive and reactor, setting up another propulsion charge, in case the Tel'taks docked to the ship hadn't survived the transition to hyperspace…

But the General and the others were suffering from poison - even after Adora had healed them. Twice, now.

So, Bow was checking the hyperdrive and reactor and preparing another charge from their remaining supplies while Sam ran her scanner over the General, trying to find out how a poison had resisted She-Ra's magic. The results she got confirmed what she had suspected.

“So, what did the magic scanner reveal?” he asked with forced levity - she could tell he was tense.

She pressed her lips together. “She-Ra's magic purged the poison from your bodies, but the poison itself wasn't destroyed - enough was left outside your bodies to affect you again. And it still lingers inside the ship.” Another quick scan, now that she knew what to scan for and had the time, showed it had spread quite far through the ship.

He cursed under his breath. “I should've known Sokar wouldn't use a poison that breaks down quickly! He probably considers area denial a bonus.”

They had been under attack by Sokar's forces and trying to escape with a crippled ship when the poison had struck, but Sam knew the General wouldn't allow that to excuse his oversight. Nor would Sam allow it to excuse her own, of course.

“We couldn't expect him to poison a ship he wanted to use,” Sha're disagreed. “Nor that he obviously never considered that he might be affected by lingering poison himself in certain circumstances.”

“Unless he has rendered his host immune to the poison,” Teal'c pointed out. “Such is known to have happened.”

And Sokar's host certainly looked alien enough to have undergone several questionable treatments, in Sam's opinion.

Sha're conceded the point with a nod.

“And he would have a way to decontaminate the ship,” Sam said.

“At the risk of revealing his tactic and poison of choice,” Daniel retorted.

Sha're shook her head. “He would simply leave no witnesses alive.”

“Charming fellow,” the General commented. “But we've got his poison to deal with. How do we decontaminate us so Adora doesn't need to keep healing us?”

“Her magic purged the poison from your body and its immediate vicinity,” Sam said. “If you wear your spacesuit and she healed you, you should be fine.”

“Should?”

“I will have to scan each individual to check, but your suit is clean inside, sir,” she told him.

“Couldn't you have opened with that?” he complained, though he was grinning. “So, do it. We need…” A beeping noise interrupted him.

Sam checked the alert on her laptop. “We're exiting hyperspace in twenty-five seconds.”

“Alright - focus on getting us to the next Stargate, then check everyone. And keep your suits on, everyone!” the General ordered.

They dropped out of hyperspace, and Sam checked the coordinates. Slightly off but within expected tolerances.

“Where are we?” Adora asked.

“In the middle of nowhere,” Catra replied, pointing at the display on the bridge.

Sam nodded as she got up. Deep Space, away from any system nearby that Sokar's forces might control or search. “Bow and I are going to check the Tel'taks, sir,” she reported. If one or both had survived the trip intact, they could leave with them and scuttle the decoy ship.

But Sam wasn't very optimistic - even under optimal conditions, taking another ship with you through hyperspace wasn't easy. Doing it with a crippled ship pushed through a subspace window by an explosive charge… Sam didn't like those odds.

“The starboard Tel'tak has been completely ripped off,” Bow reported before Sam reached the airlock on the port side. He'd had a headstart.

“Copy,” she confirmed as she opened the blast doors, revealing the wrecked airlock in front of her. “I'm checking the second Tel'tak.”

It was still docked to the ship, which was more than she had expected. But it had been exposed to vacuum - still was - as part of the boarding tactics Sokar's Jaffa had used, and that hadn't done it any good during the transition through the subspace window and subsequent travel through hyperspace. And that didn't even take the damage from the fight inside it into account.

“What's the verdict, Carter?”

She suppressed a sigh as she checked her readings - such as they were; most of the ship's systems were dead, and the rest…

“The ship's systems suffered severe damage,” she reported. “Reactor, sublight drives and hyperdrive are nonfunctional. Control crystals are damaged, and the navigational console is a total loss.” From a stray staff weapon blast, or so it looked.

“So… can you repair it?”

She hesitated. It wasn’t a total loss, but repairing it would be what an old instructor at the academy would have called ‘quite a

challenge'. Still, it was possible. They'd have to cannibalise the decoy ship for it, though - this time, the decision to use Goa'uld technology for critical parts had turned out to be helpful since the parts were somewhat compatible.

The question was, would it be better to repair the Tel'tak or to rig the Steel Fist for another trip through hyperspace to a world with a Stargate? They could only do either; the Tel'tak wouldn't survive another trip through hyperspace, and to repair it, they had to sacrifice the Steel Fist.

"We can," Sam started to explain. "But it would take longer than rigging the decoy ship for another trip, though such a trip would almost certainly wreck the Tel'tak beyond repair, meaning…"

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Deep Space, February 27th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Repair the Tel'tak or another jump with the decoy? Catra frowned. The decoy ship was already damaged, and while she wasn't a tech, she was pretty sure that improvised propulsion by explosions wasn't helping that. "How many more times can we enter hyperspace with the Steel Fist before it falls apart?" she asked.

The slight hesitation was answer enough for her.

Then Bow clinched it. *"Uh… One more time for sure. Two, maybe?"*

Her old Horde instructor, bloody bastard, would have called out: 'Are you asking or telling, cadet?' Catra looked at Adora. Her love looked grim.

"We cannot guarantee more than one additional subspace transition," Sam replied over the communicator.

"Betting everything on the next planet? With our luck so far?" Catra shook her head.

“What if they find us here before we can repair the Tel'tak?” Daniel was looking kind of pale, still. “We'd be stuck.”

“We'd be stuck at the next planet, too,” Catra retorted. “And how likely is it that they'll find us? We didn't exactly make a smooth transition.” And they were jamming whatever homing devices the Jaffa might have snuck past them.

“While we deviated from our set course, the distance was within the expected range,” Sam spoke up.

Adora shook her head. “A working Tel'tak can get us home by itself if everything else fails.”

In theory, Catra silently added. They would have to stop for supplies and avoid cabin fever quite often.

“Yeah,” Jack agreed. “Start repairing the thing, Carter.”

“Yes, sir.”

And that was it. Now, it was up to Sam and Bow. Catra leaned back in her seat. Travelling in the Tel'tak would be even more cramped than in the stealth compartment, but it beat being stuck in space because the system you picked had had its Stargate removed or whatever.

*****

Deep Space, February 28th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“We've finished repairs!”

Catra, curled up next to Adora in what remained of the Stealth compartment after it had been stripped for parts, looked up.

Bow looked tired, but he was smiling. Hell, he looked as if he were about to topple over.

“Yes! Finally!”

And now he did topple over thanks to Glimmer hugging him too enthusiastically. Even in their spacesuits, that had to hurt a little.

“Oof! Bow!”

“I'm OK!”

He looked OK, at least. Not that Catra cared too much as long as he wasn't bleeding or unconscious right now. Not after they had spent almost a full day in their suits. Granted, mostly because of the poison still lingering in the air, especially with the filters being dismantled to replace the Tel'tak's, but still! They could finally get off this wreck and return home.

Eventually, she amended as she followed Adora to the jury-rigged airlock leading to the Tel'tak. They still had to find and reach a Stargate. But with a working ship - and one with a stealth generator at that, even if it was not as good as the one built into the decoy's stealth compartment - that shouldn't be too hard.

Their luck had to get better at some point, at least.

As expected, the ship was cramped with the whole gang and two fire teams inside. Not to the point that it was standing room only, but it made a Horde Transport look roomy. And the bathroom facilities would be strained with so many people, too, even if they weren't hastily repaired like everything else.

She shuddered at the thought of the smell after a day or two. It made spending more time in the suit look like the lesser evil. At least the suit was rigged to take care of that.

Melog, next to her, turned green. Sickly green.

She patted their flank, then slipped past Isa to the cockpit - it was too small to be called a bridge. “Everyone on board,” she reported.

Adora nodded at her. “Good.”

“Airlock's sealed,” Bow said from the pilot's seat.

“Let's go!” Adora ordered.

Catra heard the ship's magnetic docking locks disengage with a slightly screeching noise, but neither Sam nor Bow looked worried, so that was probably OK. Through the cockpit's windows, she saw the decoy ship’s battered, holed hull fall out of sight as the Tel'tak turned away.

“Thrusters performing at the expected level.”

“All systems nominal.”

A small cheer went up from the fire teams. Most of them who hadn't worked a lot with Sam, Bow and Entrapta probably had been worried about the ship blowing up. Catra snorted softly at the thought as the ship continued in silence.

“We're at a safe distance,” Sam announced as the ship swung around until it pointed at the small form of the Steel Fist again.

“Alright. Trigger the scuttling charges,” Jack said.

“Yes, sir.”

A moment later, the ship vanished in a silent, expanding fireball.

Sam's hands flew over the keyboard, and the scanner strapped into the nook next to her seat vibrated a moment. “Destruction complete.”

“Good.”

Catra shrugged. They had already removed all the pieces of technology the Goa'uld didn't already know, like the scanners and improved stealth generator. But that way, the snakes might not realise it had been a decoy if they ever found it. No loose ends, even though the thought of Sokar and the other System Lords realising they had been fooled completely made Catra grin.

“Alright. Take us out of here!” Jack spoke up. “Let's go home!”

“Yes, sir. Course set.”

The ship sped up again, away from the still expanding cloud of dust left from the Steel Fist, and entered hyperspace.

Smoothly, this time.

*****

In Orbit above PT-9714, March 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

“We've arrived in orbit above the target world. Scanning for the Stargate.”

Jack O'Neill nodded at Carter's report. “Doesn't look like a good vacation spot,” he commented.

“We're not here for a vacation,” Catra retorted. “We just need to get to the Stargate and get off.”

Jack swallowed the comment he could make about the - likely intended - double-entendre; things were already tense enough after two days in hyperspace in a ship so cramped, Jack could finally top whatever stories submarine crew members could come up. Even trekking through a jungle for a week wouldn't have people on edge like that; at least on a patrol or march, you had something to do, and the exertion helped as well. Here, though? Best not to tease people. “It looks like a dustbowl.”

“Correct, sir.” Carter nodded. “The atmosphere is filled with dust particles.”

Jack frowned. “Does that match our data?”

“We don't have much data about this planet, sir. Only that it has an Earth-like atmosphere and a Stargate.” Carter sounded defensive even though it hadn't been her decision to pick this

world; it simply had been one of the worlds they knew had Stargates in range and had been picked at random.

“Is that natural?” Adora asked with a frown.

“We don't know enough to tell,” Carter replied. “But the preliminary data doesn't match what would result from volcanic eruptions. There's no radiation, though.”

So, not the result of someone going crazy with nukes.

“Is it dangerous?” Glimmer asked.

“Our suits can handle vacuum and a moon's surface,” Bow replied. “Dust won’t be a problem.”

She glared at him. “We’ve spent too long in suits already! Can we breathe the air down there?”

“Ah!” Bow’s smile turned sheepish, and Jack chuckled under his breath. “It shouldn't be that bad on the ground.”

“Then let's get down!” Glimmer blurted out. “Before I lose my sense of smell!”

“Oh, please! It's not as if you had much of one before!” Catra scoffed. “Now, me, on the other hand…”

“You grew up in the Fright Zone! I've been there; as bad as the smell is here, it's still an improvement over the stench there!”

“Sam, did you find the Stargate?” Adora spoke up, a little more loudly than usual in a blatant attempt to curb the brewing argument.

“The scan just finished,” Carter replied, staring at her screen. “We've found a mass of Naquadah that matches the mass of a Stargate…”

“That means ‘yes’,” Jack cut in with a grin.

"...but we also found significant other concentrations of Naquadah," she went on with a slight frown aimed at him. "Refined Naquadah."

Oh. Refined Naquadah meant technology - Ancient technology, most likely. Jack sighed. It looked like they couldn't just land next to the Stargate and go home. "Let's take a look before we open a gate back to our lines. I assume it's close to the Stargate?" Hopefully, it wouldn't take too long to verify there wasn't anything dangerous waiting to follow them back home, and they could leave exploring this planet to someone else.

"Yes, sir. But there's something else."

Or not. Jack looked at the screen in front of Carter and muttered a curse.

*****

Gate Area, PT-9714, March 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Yeah, someone really didn't like whatever was here," Jack O'Neill commented as he stared at the cratered area in front of him. "At least they didn't blow up the gate." The destruction stopped a few hundred yards short of the Stargate proper.

Catra knelt down and stared at a piece of twisted metal that had buried itself into the earth nearby. "Doesn't look like Horde steel. But I can't make out any markings."

"Let's check out the rest of the wreckage!" Glimmer, who had finished coughing and resealed her helmet, said.

"Is it safe?" Jack turned to look at Carter and Bow, who were huddled over the magic scanner.

"No dangerous radiation as far as we can tell," Carter replied. "But there's residual exotic radiation."

"Exotic radiation?" That didn't sound good.

“It matches the effects of Horde beam weapons,” Bow added.

Jack narrowed his eyes and looked at the craters again. Orbital bombardment by a Horde task force? They weren't even close to the borders of Horde Prime's former empire. “How long ago did this happen?” The craters weren't grown over much, but that didn't mean anything with the dust blocking sunlight and, well, this being an alien planet.

“We have to run more precise tests, sir. But judging by the rate of particles in the air… If our models from Earth fit this world, then I would guess a couple of years at most.

So… either in the last days of Horde Prime's rule… or after he had been defeated.

Jack's curse was matched by Catra's.

*****

“The explosives in the Telt'ak's are set.”

Adora nodded at Campbell's report. It was a shame that they had to destroy the ship, but they couldn't take it through the gate with them. In theory, they could leave it and then send a recovery crew through the Stargate to fly it back, but the closest Alliance-controlled worlds were months away, and neither Sam nor Bow were sure the ship would manage to make such a trip without a major overhaul first, not after everything it had gone through. It simply wasn't worth the effort. Not even for spare parts since most of the parts were cobbled together from other parts. Of course, some people - mainly outside the Alliance, but some inside the Alliance as well - would disagree and consider the risks worth it anyway. Blowing up the ship would prevent that kind of mess.

“Dibs on pulling the trigger!” Catra flashed her teeth in a wide grin.

“No fair! You can't call dibs on that!”

“I just did!”

“That doesn't count! Besides, you said it wasn’t that bad, Catra! You've got no claim to this!”

“No, I said I’ve smelt worse! I’ve got the best nose; I deserve to destroy this thing!”

Also, some people, like Glimmer and Catra, really loathed the conditions under which they had been escaping from Sokar, and destroying the ship would serve as a way to vent that frustration.

Adora shook her head at her lover and her friend bickering and walked over to Sam and Bow, both looking through the data from their scanner. “Did you find anything else?” she asked.

“Well… based on the samples of several destroyed ship parts, all of the same type, and the lack of any other ship parts near them, we think this was a major factory complex. Goa'uld technology, though we haven't found any signs of which System Lord was the owner,” Bow said.

“Ground scans confirm this. A shipyard or at least a sort of maintenance facility for smaller craft would be our current estimate,” Sam added.

Adora nodded. “And the attackers?”

“The residue left from the beam weapons matches Horde beam weapons,” Sam said. “In theory, they could be Asgard beam weapons, although we lack samples of their current arms. However, the odds of both species using weapons with so closely-matching characteristics despite a thousand years of divergences are minimal.”

Adora nodded again. “And how long ago did this happen? Was it during Horde Prime's reign?”

“No. We’ve measured the lingering exotic radiation and managed to determine the decay rate precisely enough to exclude that

possibility. This happened roughly one year ago," Sam said.

Adora suppressed a curse. That meant they had a rogue Horde task force flying around and attacking planets with orbital bombardment. And looted the remains, according to the traces Daniel, Sha're and Teal'c had examined.

Adora and her friends had suspected that there were Horde remnants unaccounted for - only Horde Prime had known how big the Horde had been; his clones only knew the fleets they had been serving in and those who had worked with theirs. And, of course, Horde Prime wouldn't have gathered his entire force to attack Etheria - he wouldn't have exposed his empire like that for a planet with only one spaceship for defence. But to have it confirmed was still a blow she could have done without. Especially after a failed mission.

"We need to find them," she said. Find them and find out what they were doing and why. If they started a war with the Goa'uld, then they were potential allies. But if they were still loyal to Horde Prime, or had started to carve out a territory for themselves, they represented a danger to the Alliance - and to the Galaxy.

"We can send a swarm of spy bots through the Stargate once we're back home," Sam said. "And some supporting facilities so they can start scouting this sector of the galaxy."

"Yes." Adora looked at the still-visible signs of battle before her and pondered the problem.

She knew this wouldn't be enough if the Horde force in this part of the galaxy were hostile. Any Alliance task force dealing with them would be operating months from the closest Alliance bases. They would need a huge fleet train, preferably with mobile yards, Horde-style - or new bases and an extended supply line back to Earth. Or a combination of both. Either option would strain current logistics, and there were also political issues with both. First Fleet hadn't fully rebuilt their fleet train yet because without it, they were tied to Etheria and the former Horde factories supplying

them. That also gave Hordak additional influence over the fleet thanks to his close relationship with Entrapta, who kept the factories running. Second and Third Fleet, though, were able to operate independently for any length of time. Some princesses and several Earth politicians didn't like that. They preferred more control over the fleets.

But the longer the supply lines got, the more inefficient they became. At a certain point, the effort needed to support fleet operations through bases and transport ships ferrying supplies from Earth and Etheria would dwarf the admittedly considerable resources needed to create and maintain a mobile fleet train. And the Goa'uld Empire was so vast, some System Lords' domains were way past that point.

But Adora and her friends had hoped to be able to delay addressing that problem until the Alliance had dealt with the closest System Lords, like Apophis. That should have built up enough trust and confidence to make it easier to build up fleets that had the resources to maintain themselves and could operate far from their home worlds.

Or without home worlds, which was another can of worms.

Adora sighed. She really didn't like to address that, but it had to be done.

"Let's wrap this up and go home. We've got a lot to do."

*****

The Clones Question Part 1

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, March 3rd, 2000

"...and then we withdrew through the Stargate, using the planned destinations to return to Alliance-controlled territory," Samantha Carter finished her verbal report. Which was the same as her written report, already filed this morning, but that had never kept the brass from holding personal debriefings.

"Thank you, Major Carter." Admiral Kearsy sounded anything but grateful. Of course, he wouldn't be happy in general - the General had been pushing hard to remove him from the Alliance Command Council, and as far as Sam understood things - she didn't like to delve too much into such things, but she couldn't avoid the gossip and office politics in her position - was that Kearsy had called in every favour and used every piece of blackmail he had on influential people in Washington. Even Kinsey had put in 'a good word' for the 'hard-working Admiral'.

Even so, Sam had heard from several people that one more misstep would see the man retired - or sent to a naval station in Alaska or Antarctica, should he choose to be difficult about it. In her opinion, that couldn't happen too soon; the man wasn't just unable to keep his bigoted religious beliefs to himself; he was also not fit to design a rowboat, much less oversee the US spaceship construction effort. If she had to deal with yet another attempt to redesign the Constitution II-class while the first ships were being built, she might abuse her friendship with the Etherians and demand that he be dealt with.

The admiral cleared his throat before he continued. "We have a few questions about your decision to destroy a functional spaceship - a stealth spaceship - before using the Stargate to withdraw."

Sam had expected that. “As my report stated, the ship wasn’t safe to enter hyperspace, and an attempt to salvage it would have risked exposure and capture by hostile forces.”

The man’s smile twisted slightly. “Your entire team took worse risks when going on this mission, I believe.”

“For a much more valuable objective, sir. Capturing a System Lord would have benefited the Alliance far more than salvaging a barely spaceworthy small craft that has been rendered temporarily functional with field repairs.” She tilted her head as she met the man’s eyes.

“That is not your call to make, Major.”

“The Supreme Commander of the Alliance made that call, sir.” Sam smiled a little more sweetly than was completely professional.

“We all agreed that the mission was worth the risk,” General Naird threw in. Kearsy glared at him, and he added: “Well, the majority did.”

“Compared to the capabilities offered by our stealth shuttles, a Tel’tak wouldn’t have added anything to our fleet,” Admiral Brown-Emerson commented in his British accent.

“Do I have to remind you that we are still building up our naval forces?” Kearsy spat. “Any spaceship is needed. And unlike a shuttle, a Tel’tak is hyperspace capable!”

“Not this Tel’tak,” Sam corrected him. “The hyperdrive would have needed a complete replacement.” Well, that was not entirely correct. Sam was pretty sure she would have been able to repair it, but it would have taken completely rebuilding the drive, and that would have only been the start. All the other components… Sam had better things to do than repair a Goa’uld craft that was already nearing obsolescence thanks to the Alliance’s magitech sensor technology.

"Even so, an enemy ship taken as a prize offers unique opportunities - especially for the kind of missions General O'Neill loves to undertake, doesn't it, Major?" Kearsy looked like he barely managed to avoid sneering when he mentioned the General's name.

"While I wouldn't presume to speak for Special Operations Command, we have allies with access to such ships if we need one, sir," Sam retorted.

Kearsy scoffed. "Allies with their own agenda! It's difficult enough to get cooperation from another branch of the service for vital tasks; relying on alien allies for critical capabilities would be foolish."

Was that a dig at her because she had insisted on realistic limitations to the US's spaceship program? Sam couldn't tell, but she wouldn't put it past Kearsy to blame her for not magically altering poorly designed frigates so they somehow made the Navy's impossible demands work.

"We haven't had any issues on that front so far," Brown-Emerson said, stressing the 'we' very slightly, before Sam could think of a good answer.

Kearsy glared at him for that, but the British officer kept his bland expression.

"Well, most Alliance operations were cooperations with the Princess Alliance, and they worked out," Naird said. "Better than our past cooperations with the Navy," he added with a brief and slightly forced chuckle. "I mean the Air Force."

Kearsy scoffed again. "The fact remains that we could have recovered a functional spaceship with a bit of an effort - and with minimal risk compared to the mission you returned from. A mission, I have to point out, that ended in dismal failure and almost led to the loss of key personnel of the Alliance! We have neither a System Lord nor a spaceship in our hands now - in fact,

we built and sacrificed two functional spaceships and have nothing to show for it!”

He wasn’t wrong about that - the mission had been a failure. But it had failed because of circumstances outside their control; the plan had been sound. But arguing that wasn’t Sam’s job. That would be up to the General, Adora and the others.

She could argue the loss of the decoy ships, though. “Those ships were built as expendable decoys for this specific mission, sir. They were never meant to be functional warships, and only one had a working hyperdrive to begin with.”

“Instead of building those… decoys… the yards could have built actual spaceships!” Kearsy stood and slammed his hands on the table.

“That is correct, sir.” Sam nodded, which seemed to surprise him - he blinked. Before he could say anything, she continued: “Although they were built by the fleet train of Third Fleet so this didn’t cut into the yard capacity assigned to the build program on Earth.” She didn’t have to add that Kearsy had been one of the most vocal backers of the decision to build up a native space industry on Earth able to fabricate warships instead of relying on Horde facilities and design - Kearsy’s scowl showed he understood perfectly what she meant.

Once again, Sam’s smile was just a shade too sweet to be professional. Maybe the influence she had thanks to her friendship with Entrapta and the others was corrupting her.

But when she had to deal with ignorant people like Kearsy, it was worth it.

*****

Earth Orbit, March 3rd, 2000

“I see. An unknown Horde Fleet has attacked an equally unknown Goa’uld shipyard.”

Glancing away from Earth's surface visible through the fake window in the room on Priest's flagship, Catra watched him rub his chin, obviously digesting the news. Or supposed news - she was pretty sure the information about their mission would have reached him before this meeting; Priest and his followers were fixated on Adora, after all, and Catra didn't doubt that the members of the Church of She-Ra were doing their best to follow their goddess's every move.

"Yes." Adora nodded. "We haven't found any clue to either's identity, though we've contacted the Tok'ra so they can look into the Goa'uld side of the thing."

"We will search our archives again for any scrap of information about the Horde's fleets we might have missed, Your Divine Highness!" Priest announced.

Adora winced, and Catra rolled her eyes. At Adora for feeling guilty about turning Horde Prime's flagship into a plant, and at Priest for going over the same data they had gone over with a comb twice before. If there had been any information about any missing fleet, or about the system that had been attacked, they'd have found it. But if Adora's faithful wanted to waste their time on that, Catra wouldn't stop them. That way, they were less likely to get into trouble.

"We've also started extending the spy bot network in the area. If the Horde fleet is still operating in the area, we'll soon know," Adora went on.

Catra wouldn't bet on that. The bots hadn't found anything so far except some debris - from Goa'uld ships, nothing from a Horde craft - in the system. She had no proof, but the attack felt like a raid - smash the enemy, grab what resources you could loot and get the hell out of the system. Though, the fact that the Horde forces had looted the planet raised questions. The average Horde Fleet didn't need to loot their enemies; they had a fleet train to supply them with anything they needed. And Goa'uld technology wasn't as advanced as Horde technology, so… "Why would they

loot the place instead of destroying everything?" she asked. "Could they be suffering from supply issues?"

Priest frowned. "They might simply have wished to analyse the technology to better understand their enemy."

That was a possibility as well. But Catra didn't think so - the Horde had been too thorough with looting. No, for some reason, they had wanted whatever Goa'uld supplies they could get.

"In any case, knowing that there is another Horde fleet fighting the Goa'uld is a great boon, Your Divine Highness. Whereas we only suspected and assumed, now we know that more of us are out there." Priest beamed at Adora.

Catra rolled her eyes again. Priest's attempt to suck up to Adora was far too blatant. They hadn't been able to take out either Apophis or Sokar and that meant the mission was a failure. That they had found some intel, and that Kul'et's fake intel must seem to have been validated by Sokar's attack and Apophis would start another purge in his court to find Sokar's spies wouldn't help much - Apophis and Sokar had already been fighting each other, and the hunt for spies endangered the Tok'ra's operatives.

"We need to contact them as soon as possible." Adora pressed her lips together. "We need to find out why they are fighting the Goa'uld."

"And we need to tell them about you, Your Divine Highness." Priest smiled widely. "Your deeds and Your wisdom will guide them to join the Alliance!"

Adora winced again, but Catra nodded. Her lover hated it, but the more clones followed her, the better for the Alliance.

"And we need to look at increasing our numbers," Priest said, bowing his head toward Adora. "We are working diligently on converting others to the Faith, of course, but we should consider building more clone pods and expanding the construction capacity of the fleets. The current cloning facilities have the capacity to

sustain our numbers, especially if we leave ground combat to the Earth forces and bots, but should we suffer heavy casualties in space, they might not be sufficient. And without using the mind-imprinting devices Horde Prime used, we'll need more time to raise and train new clones so they are able to serve when needed."

Adora frowned. "We're not making Soldiers as if they were bots!"

Catra nodded. They weren't the Horde! Either Horde.

"Joining the war would be their choice, of course," Priest said.

Adora narrowed her eyes. "We won't raise people with the expectation that they will fight in the war."

"Perish the thought!" Priest bowed his head. "That would go against all the teachings of Your Divine Highness! We would never do that! All we ask is to raise our brothers to be good people. People who will follow the example you are setting, Your Divine Highness."

Adora opened her mouth, then closed it. Catra snorted. Her lover couldn't exactly argue against people following her example. Well, she could, but that would make her a hypocrite.

But all of them here knew that anyone raised to follow She-Ra would happily join the war against the Goa'uld. And Catra was also aware that a number of their allies wouldn't be happy about Priest's plan to expand both the number of the clones and their fleets. Both on Earth and Etheria. She felt a little torn about the idea herself.

And yet, with an unknown Horde fleet out and about, they might not have a choice.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, March 4th, 2000

Jack O'Neill watched from the edge of the training field as a platoon of his soldiers struggled to clear the obstacle course they usually ran in record time. Well, they were still doing better than some regular units, but for Special Operations Command, it was not up to par.

"And this after they all had passed the zero-g assault course," Sergeant Meadows commented next to him with a deep frown.

"It's one thing to train boarding ships, it's another to spend days in the suit and fight a war in the field." And the platoon had spent more than a day in the suits already at this point, without a break. "It's still better than the old NBC drills," he added. The spacesuits were far more comfortable than those, and they didn't slow you down that much - Jack knew that from experience. But they still reduced your effectiveness in combat. Significantly in some areas, as the exercise showed, but that should be compensated for with more training and experience.

And they needed the training. The failed mission had driven that point home. Jack should have ordered everyone to keep their suits on no matter how uncomfortable it was. And he shouldn't have blindly trusted that She-Ra's magic would fix the poison. Jack should have known better than trusting a magic solution.

"I don't envy the poor bastards in the regular units," Meadows said.

Jack shrugged. They didn't have nearly enough spacesuits for every soldier - they had barely enough for his command and he had to fight with the Marines to get them and call in a favour with Entrapta - but everyone needed to be prepared for an attack with chemical weapons. Sokar's stunt had driven that lesson home. That the Jaffa would be killed as well wouldn't stop the snakes; they had no qualms about sacrificing their own troops to hurt their enemies. Especially if they were losing a battle anyway. "They're not as much at risk as our troops."

“That's true.” Meadows seemed about to add something but yelled: “Jenkins! Get up and get running, or we'll do a medical evac drill!” instead.

Jack snorted and turned away. He had seen enough and had been seen enough - an officer had to keep in touch with the troops under his command. He should run the course himself, but he had already done that yesterday, and he had a mountain of paperwork to deal with; during his absence, the stuff had multiplied, and that wasn't even counting the forms and reports he had to deal with from the mission itself.

And, he added silently with a frown as he made his way back to his office, the idiots he had to deal with. He had heard about Carter's debriefing. Not from her, of course - she would never complain about such things, at least not to him. But others paid attention.

Kearsy should have been reassigned weeks ago, but the whole thing had been delayed because the idiot knew too many influential people, and the usual posts to which you could send officers like him so they couldn't do any damage to the war effort but couldn't complain either since it was nominally a promotion were already filled.

Which said something about the Armed Forces, of course. Even in the Air Force, Jack wouldn't have expected so many staff officers to be so… Well, Daniel, always diplomatic, had called them ‘slow to change their convictions’ when they had discussed it. Carter had used ‘traditional’ with that little twist to her lips that showed that it was an insult. Jack wasn’t about to be polite inside his head and just called them stupid. And a few worse words.

Having faith was fine and dandy - a soldier needed to believe in something to risk their life in war, and whether you believed in your country or your god didn't really matter. Until one went against the other, of course. You didn't put your god over your country. And you didn't use your god as an excuse to attack your allies.

“Things would be so much simpler if Kearsy were a member of the Church of She-Ra - she could just tell him directly to behave,” Jack muttered as he entered his office, then snorted at the thought. If Kearsy converted, his career would be over anyway. His allies and supporters would turn on him in an instant, and the enemies he had made wouldn't lift a finger for him. Well, Priest might, actually.

“Sir?” Brown asked from his desk.

“Nothing. Just a silly thought,” Jack replied. “Is there anything urgent I need to deal with?”

Brown tilted his head, glancing at the sheet next to his phone, and Jack frowned. His aide knew what Jack considered urgent. Phone calls from generals and politicians generally weren't. But Brown had a habit of politely and subtly disagreeing about that. “Who called?”

“Senator Kinsey, sir. He didn't say what it was about.”

Jack sighed. “I'll call him back.” Once he had his next coffee.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, March 6th, 2000

“...and lastly, there's been concern about the proposal to clone more, ah, clones and build more Horde frigates.”

Adora nodded at the Secretary of Defense's words. “Yes. Priest is concerned about suffering casualties above their capacity to replace, especially with news about another Horde Fleet operating in the sector.” As soon as she finished, she pressed her lips together for a moment. She should have worded that a little better - ‘capacity to replace’ sounded too mechanical.

The Secretary of Defense smiled a bit weakly. “Ah, that wasn't the concern I was talking about. Our government is concerned about

using cloning technology to produce soldiers."

Adora nodded again. "I share this concern."

The man blinked, apparently surprised by her words, but recovered quickly. "Indeed. The implications on how the war is seen by the civilian population, and the effects on recruiting, are potentially problematic."

"Not to mention that this will put the question of whether we should use this technology on humans on the table," the German Verteidigungsminister added.

Adora nodded once more. They had gone over that with Priest. Some wouldn't see cloned humans as people - some already didn't consider Horde clones people. And not just those who called them 'soulless abominations'.

"We're aware of that," Glimmer cut in before anyone else could speak up. "It's a difficult decision with many far-reaching consequences. I doubt any of our countries, whether on Earth or on Etheria, are ready to handle the changes such a decision would cause in society. There are many questions that need to be answered."

"Not the least the question of what you should do once your mass-produced clone soldiers have no more war to fight in," the British minister commented. "Her Majesty's Government opposes the use of cloning technology for military recruitment."

"As does France," his French colleague added.

"The United States' position is that at this point, there is no need for such drastic, unprecedented and potentially destabilising technology. The risks are far too great when compared to its moral implications and questionable military benefits."

"Brecht's saying about the Government dissolving its people and electing a new one comes to mind," the German minister commented.

Adora didn’t quite get that, but the rest matched what she had heard in the leadup to this meeting after Priest's proposal had been passed on to the rest of the Alliance. And she agreed with the stance. You couldn't just let anyone, well, anyone with the technology and facilities to build and run so many cloning pods, mass-produce people as if they were bots. That went against everything the Alliance stood for. It was just wrong.

“While my government doesn't disagree,” the minister from Norway spoke up, “we also cannot overlook that the Alliance is already producing bots, and some of them are sapient. The implications are the same.”

“They're not the same!” the American protested.

“Morally, they are the same.”

“Sapient is sapient,” Entrapta commented, nodding emphatically. “No matter how you’re built. Whether metal, ceramic, crystal or biological, it's all just matter, in the end, nothing more.”

The Secretary of Defense looked as if he wanted to disagree but held his tongue.

“The scale is vastly different, though. As I recall, the sapient bots are only produced in tiny numbers,” the British minister said.

“So far,” the minister from Norway retorted. “What if we end up needing more smart combatants and turn to bots?”

That was a good question.

“We'll produce more dumb bots and put human veterans in command of their units,” Catra replied. “That's more effective than producing more sapient bots who have no experience.”

Entrapta nodded several times. “Yes. We found that out in the Horde War. The data is very conclusive.”

Adora wasn’t the only one who winced, though in her case, it was because she had torn through Horde bots without a thought.

“I think we can cross this bridge once we reach it,” the French minister said.

That went against the basic principle of planning ahead, in Adora's opinion. Then again, it also wasn’t smart to start trouble when you didn't need to - and they didn’t need to make the problem with clones worse. Not when the real problem - one of the real problems, she corrected herself - hadn't been addressed yet. “So, we're in agreement that there won’t be any cloning of humans for military reasons,” she said.

“Yes.”

“Yes.”

“Not for any reason!”

“We didn’t agree to that!”

“It's implied!”

“It's not.”

“What do you need clones for?”

“There are several possible reasons for cloning people.”

“None of them are valid!”

“You can't dismiss them without even hearing them!”

“We just went over the reason they are not valid!”

“It’s unnatural!”

Adora cleared her throat, stopping the growing argument in its tracks. She made a mental note to ask around what this was about. “So, that's about cloning humans. But the Horde clones

aren't humans. Their society is based on cloning - they do not reproduce sexually. And they are a sovereign species. If they decide to increase their numbers, that's their decision. It would be like us telling people they aren't allowed to have children." That had been an excellent argument from Priest, Adora had to admit.

"That's not the same!" the Secretary of Defense blurted out. "You can't compare individual decisions to found a family to mass cloning!"

"You can't force your family norms on aliens," his colleague from Norway retorted.

"You have to consider the impact of each decision," the American shot back. "As with the bots, numbers matter!"

"It's not our decision in the first place."

As the other ministers started to debate again, Catra, who had been uncharacteristically quiet so far, Adora realised, leaned over and whispered: "Wanna bet that this is actually about not wanting the clones to outnumber their forces if they chose to?"

Priest had mentioned that as well, Adora knew. And he might have been correct. Even though his proposal wouldn't even come close to doing that - not even if he wanted; the Horde didn't have the cloning pods for it and wouldn't have them for a long time.

Then again, it wasn't a baseless concern. There were other clones out there, after all. Clones they didn't know anything about.

*****

Colorado Springs, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, March 7th, 2000

"Carter! Entrapta! Come in! Don't mind the neighbours - they still haven't adjusted to my new commute!"

“General.” Samantha Carter nodded a greeting as she stepped into his home.

“What did the neighbours do? I didn't notice anything,” Entrapta asked behind her, turning around to peer at the neighbouring houses, semi-hidden by the three shuttles parked outside.

“Nothing. The General is joking,” Sam told her.

“I’m not!” he protested with a grin. “And they're watching us attentively, you can be sure of that!”

“Isn't that rude?”

“It’s their job.” He smiled a little wryly. “When I got promoted to General, the Air Force bought up all the lots bordering mine for security purposes. If they hadn't, the Homeowner Association would have tried to burn down my home for parking my shuttle in the driveway. The others are in the living room - make yourself at home!”

“Alright!” Entrapta nodded, and Sam caught her pulling up her multitool as they entered the General's living room. Probably to check what a Homeowner Association was.

“Sam! Entrapta!”

“Hello!”

“Greetings.”

Daniel, Sha're and Teal'c were already there, occupying the couch and one seat. She had expected that - Teal'c would have flown with the General in his personal stealth shuttle while Daniel and Sha're usually took a normal shuttle from the Alliance pool when they needed to travel. For now piloted by a soldier, but Sha're was training to take over.

“Who wants a beer?” The General appeared carrying a tray filled with snacks and his favourite beer as well as some sodas.

Sam noted that the couch table was already covered with more beer bottles and bowls of food. As expected. German beer, mostly.

“It's been a while since we had a get-together here,” he said as he took a seat and Sam grabbed a soda for herself.

“Your Homeowner Association sounds more dangerous than the norm,” Entrapta commented while her hair grabbed two sodas and a bowl of tiny marshmallows. “I haven't found anything about other such groups using arson.”

“That was a joke,” Daniel said, frowning at Jack.

“Yes. Though I am sure they wished they could run me out of town when Uncle Sam took over.”

“Ah.” Entrapta nodded, then started munching from the bowl and occasionally taking sips from the can.

“Adora and the others were held up at headquarters but should arrive soon,” the General went on after downing half his beer. “The thing about the clones really raised some hackles.”

“I don’t understand the problem,” Entrapta said. “The clones are not subjects of any country on Earth. So, why should they listen to anyone on Earth about how they should reproduce? Also, the Alliance needs more ships, and ships need crews, and the clones have the means to provide us with both.”

She wasn't technically wrong, Sam knew, but it was a very blunt way to look at it.

Daniel cleared his throat. “It's a complex issue. Leaving aside the, err, ethical and religious concerns, some people feel that the Horde is already the most powerful member of the Alliance since they control the vast majority of the Alliance's spaceships. Hearing that they plan to expand while Earth is still so far behind in building up their own ships might make them concerned about the future. And there's still lingering resentment about the changes to Earth society the Alliance caused. Some feel that if Etheria could

make them adapt their way of life, they should be able to reciprocate."

"But neither Etheria nor the Horde prohibit people from having relationships and families with anyone or discriminate against it." Entrapta frowned in the slightly pouty way she usually did when struggling with an unfamiliar concept. "So, what is there to reciprocate?"

Daniel hesitated, and the General said: "For some people, not being able to tell others how to live their lives makes them feel discriminated against. You can find a lot of them in Homeowner Associations."

Entrapta blinked. "That makes no sense."

"It doesn't." The General shrugged.

"I have also heard that there is concern amongst some leaders on Earth that their population advantage might be negated by mass-cloning by the time Earth's production capacity for advanced technology would reach parity with the Horde's," Teal'c spoke up.

"But that's baseless!" Entrapta shook her head, her hair tendrils almost spilling a bowl of tiny crackers. "The resources needed for mass cloning on such a scale… Just the need to educate every clone would be beyond the means of the current population, and that's without taking all the physical resources into account! Not to mention they don't have much experience with rearing new clones. Sure, you could use Horde Prime's memory implant technology, but at that point, you might as well just build bots! And that will cripple your science research, which means you couldn't develop better technology, which means your ships - which would require tons of resources as well - would become obsolete, meaning you'd need even higher numbers to compensate… It just doesn't work that way! Not in the time projected for Earth to adapt to advanced technology, at least."

Sam nodded - she had run the numbers as well. Though longer-term, a dedicated focus on cloning and expansion could theoretically enter exponential growth.

“It's completely irrational,” Entrapta huffed and sat back down, stuffing her mouth with two tendrils full of snacks.

“That's politics for you,” the General commented. He leaned back. “Anyway, it's not as if anyone can stop the clones from doing what they want, so it's going to blow over.”

“That's what Hordak said as well. The not being able to stop them, I mean,” Entrapta said. “Earth can't dictate how the clones should live.”

While correct, Sam was sure the former warlord hadn't meant the moral aspects of the question but had been talking realpolitik. Earth simply lacked the power to enforce their views, even if they wanted to stoop that low.

“Unfortunately, that doesn't mean some people won't try,” Daniel said.

“And if your press gets involved, they might try to draw parallels to how the Goa'uld reproduce in large numbers,” Sha're added.

Sam winced. It was likely only a question of time until the cloning plans were leaked to the public. And once the various extremists heard about it, their reactions wouldn't be pretty.

She finished her soda and grabbed a beer, but her mood had already been soured. So much for a nice evening with her friends!

*****

“Hello, everyone!”

“Hello!”

“Hello!”

Following behind Adora, Glimmer and Bow, Catra stuck to nodding in greeting at the others already occupying the living room. At least they weren't too late - the group didn't look as if they had been having too much fun yet.

“Sorry for being late, but we had a meeting run long.” Adora smiled at the others with that expression of hers that showed she felt responsible for something that wasn't her fault.

“As usual,” Catra commented as she snagged a beer - one of the German ones, not the American stuff and waited for Adora to pick a seat for them.

“Not every meeting runs longer than expected,” Adora retorted.

“But every meeting is expected to run long,” Catra shot back. Oh, salmon rolls! She grabbed the bowl and ignored Jack's snicker.

“If every meeting is expected to run long then you need to adjust the allotted time for the meeting so it matches expectations,” Entrapta said. “Data doesn't lie.”

“Then they would run even longer. It's a rule,” Jack said.

“But that doesn't make sense!”

Adora grabbed a beer herself and some hot chips, then sat down, and Catra first perched on the armrest before she slid onto Adora's lap, startling her lover with a grin.

“Hey!”

“That's my line,” Catra said before pushing a roll into her mouth. Oh! Mh! “Good rolls,” she told Jack after swallowing. “Where did you get them?”

“Brown got them for me,” he admitted. “I planned to get them myself, but there was a problem with the training schedule. And he probably wanted to avoid complaints from the German police if

I parked the shuttle in front of the local supermarket again," he added with a grin.

"You used a shuttle for a grocery run?" Daniel stared at him.

"I put it in stealth mode and had it hover above the ground," Jack replied. "So, I didn't break any traffic laws."

"Except for air traffic regulations, sir." Sam sounded exasperated, but Catra could spot a smile on her lips.

"I was flying too low for that to apply. And I had a flight plan filed per regulations. Not my fault that the German official thought I was joking." Jack shrugged. "Anyway, Brown had it handled like a good aide should."

"Or a lawyer," Daniel commented.

"He's too honest for a lawyer."

Catra snorted at that. The aide sounded quite sneaky to her - sneaky enough, at least, to handle Jack's antics. Of course, Jack was sneaky enough to let him do it, so… Whatever. She finished her beer, then called out: "Hand me another one, Daniel?"

"Why don't you get up and grab one yourself?" Glimmer asked.

"I'm needed here to make sure Adora relaxes," Catra told her with a grin while she took the can from Daniel. "She needs another one as well, by the way."

"I haven't finished my first yet," Adora protested.

"You can still use another," Catra retorted. The meetings had been tedious. So much posturing and horse-trading just to get things done! Almost as bad as Horde meetings, but you didn't have to fear literal backstabbers. Well, you probably didn't; there could always be some fanatic. Or someone going crazy; the stress of waging war could break people.

“So… what movie are we watching?” Adora asked.

“Well, we have watched Star Wars twice, so I was thinking something new,” Jack said. “Sorry, Teal'c.”

Teal'c nodded in response but didn't comment.

“And I was told by someone,” Jack pointedly looked at Daniel, “that you need more exposure to movie culture to truly appreciate ‘so bad they're good’ movies.”

“All I said was that to enjoy those sorts of movies, more context might be needed,” Daniel told him with a frown. “And all the movies you suggested were just bad.”

“Enough beer and every movie starts looking good,” Jack shot back. “Anyway, with the classics out, I thought I'd take a page out of Etheria's book and get the latest movie.” He flashed his teeth in a wide grin, reached behind his seat and pulled out a small case. “Behold the latest Hollywood blockbuster: ‘Space Pirates’.”

“Isn't that still in the cinemas?” Daniel asked.

“I got an Etherian bootleg,” Jack said.

Glimmer groaned. “Disney will complain again if that gets out, and the negotiations about a copyright deal will stall again.”

Catra shrugged. That wasn't her problem. Besides, Glimmer could always give in and bribe them with magic healing or something if things were going wrong. “Come on, put it on.”

“Alright.” Jack stood up and walked over to the TV.

Catra leaned back into Adora and got comfortable.

*****

“We absolutely need to show this to Mermista!” Catra blurted out when the end credits started rolling.

“We absolutely can't show this to Mermista!” Glimmer protested.

“But they so ripped off her and Sea Hawk! Princess Siren even looks like her, and they got her attitude down to the way she rolls her eyes!” Catra giggled. “And the hero is a space smuggler named ‘Falcon’ with a laser cutlass whose ship gets wrecked in the very first scene and he just walks it off!”

“Exactly!” Glimmer shook her head. “She'll go ballistic.”

“There are bootlegs around already. Mermista will hear about it sooner or later anyway,” Catra pointed out.

“That doesn’t mean we need to tell her!” Glimmer insisted.

“Of course we do! That way, we can see her reaction firsthand!” Oh, Mermista would go ballistic! Sea Hawk would probably love it - the actor playing his expy was great. “And we need to get the cast to visit Etheria!”

“You want to reward them for ripping off our history?” Glimmer sounded shocked.

“More like ripping off our stories.” Catra shrugged again. She didn't care - it was a great movie. And speaking of that… “Bow! I'll need a copy for us!”

“OK.”

“Bow!”

As Bow tried to placate Glimmer, Catra smiled. That had been a great movie night. Just the thing to relax and have fun.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, March 9th, 2000

"...and behind me, in front of the White House, a crowd has turned out to protest the production of clone soldiers. While the protesters are, so far, peaceful, the mood is quite riled up, and the police in riot gear are standing by to intervene."

Behind the reporter who was almost breathlessly narrating, Jack O'Neill could see the crowd waving various signs around. He wasn't quite sure - the cameras didn't really linger on them - but he thought he saw something about 'soulless hordes' next to the dozens of identical "Say NO! to unnatural procreation!' and 'No Kid Factories!" signs. Someone must have mass-produced them for the protest, he thought with a snort.

Then the frame froze, and Major What'shisname, Greaves, stepped up and addressed the room. "As you can see with this news clip - just a sample from various others - we're already seeing protests from the public against cloning people."

Not for the first time since he had received his personal stealth shuttle, Jack had to admit that while it was great to be able to commute to any location on Earth or the moon from his home - or any planet with a Stargate if he took a trip to Stargate Command - it came with a few drawbacks. Such as not having an excuse not to attend a stupid meeting halfway across the continent from your base because travelling there wouldn't take him much time at all.

And so he had to listen to a staff officer who must have risen through the ranks in Public Affairs without ever seeing the field, much less combat. Major Greaves certainly seemed way too concerned about this whole thing. Then again, that was his thing. Jack on the other hand.. If he ever found out who got him on this committee, someone would regret it. He was special forces, not public relations!

"Protests by fringe elements driven by religious nutcases," General Barbier said in his distinct French accent. "If we listened to them, we might as well drop any advanced technology and go back to horse and carriage."

“They're not Amish!” Greaves protested. “They have significant influence amongst the more conservative, err, conservatives.”

“In the United States, maybe. I can assure you that such fringe elements do not influence French policies.”

“Her Majesty's Government also isn't in the habit of listening to demands rooted in irrational beliefs or based on sensational movies,” Admiral Brown-Emerson added. He wasn't a PR specialist, either. Must have annoyed someone back in Merry Old England.

“Unless they donate to your election campaigns,” General Naird commented. Of course, he would jump at the chance of getting on a committee for the networking and influence. At least his background - Signals - was something slightly related to this bullshit. “Didn't one of your Lords start a petition to clone a dragon?”

“That's not a rejection of cloning technologies - quite the opposite, in fact,” the British admiral retorted with a straight face.

“You can't claim that's rational, though.” Naird snorted. “And I bet the guy has come up with this after watching Jurassic Park.”

Brown-Emerson chuckled, conceding the point.

“Sirs?” Greaves cleared his throat. “While fascinating, this meeting is being held to discuss the potential issues the adaption of cloning technology for procreation could have for the image of the Alliance.”

“It's just the Horde clones who are doing it, and they, well, are clones,” Naird said. “No other country has passed legislation to allow the cloning of people.” He gestured at the screen. “Those people are protesting an imaginary threat!”

“That is correct, sir. However, what people believe, regardless of its veracity, still matters,” Greaves retorted. “If the population - or

a part of the population - thinks the Alliance is building factories to churn out cloned soldiers, that will have repercussions."

Jack wasn't really concerned about a bunch of idiots falling for rumours. But the people using those idiots? The people politely voicing 'concerns' about the 'unprecedented expansion of what is arguably already the most powerful member of the Alliance', as one of them had put it? Those could be trouble. Even though Jack had mixed feelings himself about the Horde expanding. Still…

He scoffed, drawing the room's attention. "And even for the Horde, who have been cloning each other for centuries, it's not going to be easy to expand. This isn't a game where soldiers spawn fully trained and equipped at the push of a button."

"No one is expecting that!" Greaves protested.

Jack had a mind of showing the Major the clips from the more conservative TV channels Daniel had collected. Some idiots certainly seemed to think they were living in Starcraft. "Anyway, we're not going to get buried in clones." Carter and Entrapta, and they would know best, had run the numbers, and Jack had checked them himself.

"We can't tell people that, though," Naird pointed out. "That's a military secret!"

"We don't have to tell them that. We can simply not comment but let experts explain the truth," Barbier countered.

"That would be the same! We can't let the enemy know about our production capacity!" Naird shook his head.

"If the Goa'uld have spies on Earth, then speculation about cloning and training capacity is the least of our worries," Jack said. "We just did a dangerous mission to convince the snakes that we're at war with the Horde, remember?"

Naird glared at him. "Of course I do! But we still cannot reveal such details about our military capacity!"

“I think we should consider it if only to counter the narrative that we're on the verge of people cloning armies,” Greaves cut in. “If fear of this scenario continues to spread, it's bound to do a lot more damage to the Alliance's capability to conduct this war. Not to mention the consequences if people start to suspect that friends and family could be replaced by clones.”

“Surely that is not a realistic scenario!” Barbier exclaimed.

“Never underestimate the stupidity of the average man,” Jack muttered.

“I suggest we create a task force for combatting disinformation and rumours,” Naird said.

“Good idea,” Jack said. Naird looked surprised at his support, but as long as Jack wasn't on that force, he was all for it. Maybe they could have the Department of Education do it. It certainly seemed as if the world - Jack didn't believe that America was unique in that area - was in need of better education, so people didn't believe every nonsense.

*****

The Clones Question Part 2

Earth Orbit, Solar System, April 10th, 2000

"...and as our first batch of new brothers is ready to take their first steps into the universe today, Her Divine Highness Herself is attending this joyous occasion to welcome them with her blessings!"

Adora didn't wince when the assembled clones broke out cheering at Priest's prompting, but she felt her cheeks grow warm. She shouldn't have agreed to this, all the public relations concerns be damned! It was dubious, anyway, that her presence would help make the clones more acceptable. As Mr Brown and Julie had explained, there was considerable overlap between those on Earth who were afraid of an army of 'soulless clones' taking over Earth and those who considered her a 'false heathen demon tempting the faithful', someone even worse than the Goa'uld, just because the Church of She-Ra was still growing on Earth.

It wasn't as if she wanted to convert people to worship her - or have anyone worship her at all!

On the other hand, those newborn clones didn't deserve to feel snubbed and abandoned just because Adora felt embarrassed. It was bad enough that some bigots hated them already before they were even born - or decanted, as Catra called it.

Priest was correct that they were newborns, and newborn children deserved love and care, not hatred and ignorance. It was the duty of She-Ra to protect people, and she wouldn't shirk it.

So she smiled at Priest, tried to ignore how he and everyone else bowed their heads and stepped forward to the small podium placed in front of the cloning pods in the main cargo bay of the frigate they had converted into a support ship, and smiled.

“Thank you, everyone,” she started the short speech she had prepared last night - after a final check that Catra hadn't sneaked in the suggestions she had mentioned last night. “I am happy to be here to see new people entering our world, our universe. They are the first of a new generation, the first after Horde Prime was finally defeated.”

Experience made her pause in time to let the clones curse Horde Prime. She managed not to wince when she noted that they had picked up a few more creative insults from Catra. That bit certainly would be cut before it was aired by any American broadcasting company.

“They are the first generation to be raised differently - to be raised as people in their own right. The first to benefit from what you all have fought and struggled for - and earned - the right to pursue your own path in life, to find happiness according to your own desires, not according to one being's whims and dictates. You called them your brothers, and they are, but they are also your first children. Treat them as such - raise them with love, care and understanding. Do not force your own expectations on them, but let them decide how they want to live their life.”

She felt more than a little like a hypocrite. Here she was preaching about childcare when she had been raised as a child soldier by Shadow Weaver. But that didn't mean she was lying, or wrong.

“Above all, accept and love them no matter their choices, but guide them as well so they can make their own decisions and live with the consequences.”

Adora took a deep breath and blinked - her eyes were feeling a little wet.

“In short, be their loving family.”

She slowly nodded, and the clones cheered again.

“Her Divine Highness has spoken, and Her Wise Words shall be heeded!” Priest declared. He bowed deeply to Adora and then

turned to face the assembled clones. “Now, let's not dally any longer and welcome our newest children to our family!”

Adora turned to watch the rows of cloning pods behind her. The first one, the one at the right end of the front row, briefly glowed, illuminating its interior. The liquid inside it was quickly drained, revealing a new clone. Several cables and tubes connecting him to the pod were withdrawn, and Adora suppressed a slight shudder at the memory of Horde Prime using a similar mechanism for himself.

But then she heard a hissing sound, and the lid of the pod slowly rose as warm air dried the clone inside.

He wasn't moving, though. Adora could see him breathing, but he wasn’t moving. But if something were wrong, the machines and sensors would have caught it. And Priest didn't seem worried, so this was normal.

Then the clone opened his eyes, blinking confusedly - at her, Adora realised. “Who…?” he whispered. “Where am I? Who am I?”

“You are a clone, same as we are,” Priest told him. “The youngest member of our family.”

The clone looked from Adora to Priest, then at Adora, and finally down at himself.

“And this is Her Divine Highness, She-Ra, Princess of Power! We owe her our freedom and our lives!”

Adora blinked as the clone’s eyes widened and darted back to stare at her. “She-Ra…”

Before she could tell him to call her Adora, Priest cried out: “Praise her Divine Highness!”, and the other clones took up the call.

Including the new clone whispering it as two clones helped him out of the pod and led him to the side, where clothes and other necessities were waiting.

Adora turned to frown at Priest - she hadn't been told about that part! - but he was already stepping up to the next pod.

*****

Portsmouth Naval Shipyard, Maine, United States of America, Earth, April 15th, 2000

"...and it's with great pleasure and pride that we have gathered to watch the launch of the Constitution II, the mightiest warship ever to be constructed on Earth. May she serve as admirably as her famous predecessor, the oldest warship still in service!"

Samantha Carter clapped her hands politely as everyone else present applauded. She managed not to roll her eyes as Admiral Baker continued his speech.

The man was technically correct - the Constitution II was the largest warship built so far on Earth and outgunned the Flower II-class built by the United Kingdom even without taking her fighter complement into account. Which was a good thing since the Corsair IIIs that were supposed to be carried by her were still in the testing phase. Although the fighters were about to enter mass production as soon as testing showed that Sam's fixes for the last issues worked. Which it would - Sam and Entrapta had done the fixes personally. Compared to the work on the Constitution II, the project had run almost smoothly for its scope.

Of course, the fact that the Corsair III was a joint project of the United States, the United Kingdom, France and Germany, and one where the US Navy hadn't been able to take the lead, had helped there. If they had incorporated every damn 'suggestion' by the Navy, they would still be in the planning phase for the next prototype. If they had simply copied the Horde fighter design, maybe adapted it a bit, they would have had squadrons of them

entering service already, but if there was one thing the Earth part of the Alliance agreed on, it was that they didn't want to rely on copying designs but create their own despite the cost.

By her estimation, the Constitution II could have been launched about a year earlier, and at a much, much lower cost, if they had stuck to the original design for a frigate instead of trying to construct a ship that would do the job of both a frigate and an escort carrier.

And, in her opinion, clearly if diplomatically stated in her reports, the design was a failure as a carrier. It had less firepower than a Horde frigate despite being bigger. And a single squadron of fighters simply wasn't worth the additional crew, space and supplies requirements. More shuttles would have been better and would have significantly helped with the capacity to conduct rescue, scouting and even special operations. But the Navy had argued that the new ships' 'dual focus' would let them gain critical experience with both gunship and carrier operations in space at the same time and that the exploding costs were worth it since that way, they would be able to save money when designing the fleet carriers and battleships they wanted.

Sam would believe that when it happened - and after double- and triple-checking the budgets.

"And now, let's watch as the newest ship in the service of the United States takes to the sky!" Baker finished, gesturing with his arm at the ship in its berth behind him.

For a moment, nothing happened. Sam heard some of the audience starting to whisper - mostly, but not exclusively the civilians present, politicians and other notables, laypeople who expected an outdated rocket launch.

But modern spaceships with inertial compensators didn't launch on a pillar of fire. The ship silently started to rise, slowly clearing the berth's walls. Once she was clear, she accelerated, although

still far more slowly than she could, to avoid blasting the audience with a sonic boom.

Even so, it didn't take long for the ship to become a speck in the sky.

While the audience started chatting excitedly about the - in Sam's opinion rather mundane - event, she checked her laptop. According to the scanner in the Spacelab, the Constitution II's systems were performing according to their specifications, and the ship was following the pre-planned route for her maiden flight.

Good. Sam felt a bit relieved even though she knew the odds of anything going wrong were very slim. Not slim enough that she would have been allowed on the ship for this, though. In any case, this was now officially no longer her problem - at least until something did go seriously wrong.

"Major Carter, you must be feeling very proud to see your project coming to such an impressive conclusion!"

She turned to smile, politely, at Admiral Baker. "It is good to see the ship fly," she said, "but my part in the project was limited to troubleshooting when necessary." Which had been far too often the case, in her opinion. "You should congratulate the design team responsible for this." And, of course, the ship still needed significant time to work up until she was ready for active service.

"Already did!" He beamed at her. "And you know what they said?"

Sam managed not to channel the General and comment that she was sure he would tell her. "No, sir?" she said instead.

"That you were essential for the project's success! Now, as we both know, they wouldn't say this if this weren't true. So, again, congratulations! The Navy is in your debt."

Sam smiled, but inwardly, she felt quite differently. Those bastards were only praising her in order to blame her for any problems that

would appear during the ship's maiden flight or the shakedown cruise.

Well, Sam wasn't going to let them do this to her. Her reports were already filed and would set things straight if anyone tried to scapegoat her.

So she smiled and nodded - and hoped the admiral would turn to someone else soon so she could slip away and get back to more important work.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, April 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra put down the report from Priest and shook her head. The clone knew how to mince words, even when writing military reports. But even flavoured quite optimistically, the results remained: Training the newborn clones to be competent crewmen for Horde ships would take six months at the very least, and only if you defined competent as "won't endanger the ship trying to do their duties" and focused on specialising as much as possible.

Which wasn't a good way to run a navy, as Catra knew from her time in the Horde. You wanted as much redundancy as possible in your crews to compensate for losses. And you wanted experienced sailors, both ratings and officers. During the Horde war, the Salinean fleet had had inferior ships but much better crews, and that had told in most engagements where they hadn't been outnumbered to a significant degree. And even outnumbered, they had inflicted disproportionate losses on the Horde forces.

So, in order to actually be effective, they would need to staff the Fourth Fleet with a solid core of experienced clones from the other fleets. That would reduce the crew quality in the existing fleet since those clones would have to be replaced. And cause some friction if you mixed crews from different fleets on the same ship -

or even in the same task force. Third Fleet had developed a very different culture than Second Fleet or First Fleet, not that the two latter fleets were identical either; Hordak and WrongHordak ran their forces quite differently.

They could avoid some of the friction by simply taking the cadre for the new fleet from a single fleet. Third Fleet would be the obvious choice, but that would mean that fleet would suffer the lion's share of the drain of experienced crews. And having new fleets so closely associated with existing fleets could, in the long run, damage the entire fleet's cohesion.

Although Catra wasn't sure that just forming new fleets with new cultures would help much with cohesion either. Maybe having more crews move around between ships and fleets would help, but with the way Third Fleet was basically just the Church of She-Ra's naval branch, as Jack had put it once, it might cause more problems than it would solve.

Problems Horde Prime hadn't had to deal with since he had just programmed the minds of his clones to get them as skilled and loyal as he wanted them to be. Loyal little drones. She shivered at the memory of being under his control, ready to lay down her life for him, ready to fight Adora for him… No one should have that kind of power!

Fortunately, all the data about that kind of 'programming' had been wiped on the orders of Hordak, WrongHordak and Priest - not even Entrapta had protested against losing data forever. So, no idiot could have the bright idea of using this technology to speed up training, and Catra wouldn't have to claw off their face for suggesting it, either.

Still, between the need to train all those new clones and crews and draining the existing crews of cadre, it meant that for the next twelve months or so, the Alliance's naval strength would be diminished.

She quickly ran the numbers on her pad. If everything worked out reasonably well, they'd reach the point where they would see the first actual increase in numbers and total effectiveness in about a year, but the individual ships would still be less effective than they currently were since a percentage of their crews would be new clones getting training. That could be improved with a dedicated training command, though setting that up would cost resources as well. However, once running, it should streamline and speed up the training of new clones and improve crew effectiveness.

And having a centralised Horde training command should also help with force cohesion.

Nodding, she started jotting down a proposal she could run past Hordak, Wrong Hordak and Priest. She could put it to the Command Council, but this was Horde business; the idea of a centralised Alliance Naval Training Command had been shot down from the start since none of the Earth navies wanted to adapt to a different naval culture, much less the Horde traditions, and technical training wouldn't help much with everyone using different classes of ships.

Just having a standardised Naval Tactics Course based on the Horde experience for all naval officers to take had been an achievement, and even that had required letting NATO take the lead in Alliance Special Operations training.

Sometimes, Catra really missed having the power to just order people to do things the right way or get shot. On the other hand, having such power also came with a lot more paperwork and everyone and their mother coming to her with problems they should have been able to solve themselves, cutting into her time to actually tackle the important issues.

She took a look at her proposal. It wasn't very detailed, but it didn't have to be; that stuff was best left to those with more experience in the specifics. But it outlined the pros and cons quite nicely. Now, all that was left was to send it to the Fleet leaders.

She was just getting around to that when an alert came in. Not an emergency, but urgent?

Oh. The spy bot network had discovered the missing Horde fleet.

She quickly sent her proposal and got up to head to the meeting room. The Alliance would have to deal with this new development.

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Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, April 18th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"So, what's the situation?" Jack O'Neill asked as he entered the meeting room and found the Etherians already present. Of course, he had had to take the Stargate from Earth while they were living down the hall.

"Hello, everyone!" Daniel said and Jack knew without looking behind him that he was frowning at Jack.

Jack ignored it. The Etherians had called for an urgent meeting, so time was of the essence. At least, that was his excuse. Besides, a meeting was a meeting; the sooner you got it started, the less time ended up being wasted. Though this was a peculiar meeting - besides the princesses, both Hordak and WrongHordak were present, but not Priest.

"Hi there!"

"Hello."

"Thank you for coming so quickly."

"Of course, we came."

"Indeed."

His friends apparently didn't want to go with the program. Foiled again. Jack sighed as he took his usual seat next to Carter, who

apparently had stayed the night on Etheria, probably burning the midnight oil with Entrapta again.

“We've discovered the missing Horde force,” Adora said once everyone was seated.

“One of the potentially missing Horde forces - there could be others,” WrongHordak cut in.

“A Horde force with which we haven't been in contact before,” Adora corrected herself. “Though it seems they are the ones that attacked the Goa'uld shipyard we found. They’re operating in the same area, at least, and they're attacking Goa'uld forces.”

“Oh?” Jack raised his eyebrows.

“Yes, sir.” Carter nodded. “We've been able to observe a battle between a task force of standard Horde frigates and what has been identified as a fleet under the command of Sokar.” She pushed a button on her laptop, and a holoprojection appeared in the middle of the room. Must have made an upgrade, Jack noted. Or just tapped into the existing hardware of the room. “The Goa'uld force was completely destroyed in short order, the expected outcome given the numerical and technological superiority of the Horde force. Interestingly, we observed salvage efforts afterwards - the clones are working on recovering two Ha'taks that were disabled instead of destroyed in the fighting.”

“They’re trying to recover the ships themselves? Not just stripping them for parts?” Jack asked.

“Yes, sir.” The projection zoomed in on those two ships, showing a few Horde craft near them and docked to them.

“That's a major effort for an inferior ship,” Jack commented. Before meeting the Ethetrians and the Horde, Stargate Command had been hoping to recover a Ha'tak by any means necessary, and Jack had familiarised himself with the plans made. Salvaging a ship disabled through damage took a lot of work unless it was

precise sabotage you could easily fix. Which getting your engines blasted off by focused naval fire wasn't.

“Indeed,” Teal'c agreed. “They are either not worried about being caught in the middle of the recovery operation by reinforcements or feel confident to repel any such force.”

“It's easy to feel confident in their position,” Jack said. “Though that makes it even weirder that they are bothering about Ha'taks.”

“Yes.” Entrapta nodded several times. “Are they trying to gather more data on their enemies? But between all the Ha'taks they destroyed and the shipyard they looted, they already should know all that is to know about Ha'taks. Unless they were very unlucky or sloppy with their sensors.”

“That is unlikely. Clones are trained better than that,” Hordak said with a frown.

“Yes.” WrongHordak agreed. “Most of us have had those skills ingrained by Horde Prime's conditioning and then practised them continuously. They are almost reflexes at this point.”

“But Horde Prime's death was a heavy blow to his clones,” Bow commented. “That’s like losing a princess without a successor ready to be crowned, and in such cases, a kingdom usually suffered an upheaval on Etheria. These clones would have suddenly lost their connection to Horde Prime without anyone ready to step in and lead them like First, Second and Third Fleet had. We can't really count on them to just keep going as usual.”

Daniel nodded in obvious agreement.

“That wouldn't have been enough for them to forget their training,” Hordak retorted. “And as our new intel shows, they fought effectively and at a level we would expect, so it's unlikely that they would have suffered a loss of effectiveness in just one area of expertise.”

Weirder things had happened, but Jack had to agree with the former warlord. “We need more information to tell.”

“Yes,” Glimmer said. “Before we contact them, we need to know what they're doing and why.”

“We can ask them when we contact them.” Perfuma smiled. “I'm sure they'll be curious about us as well - especially about their brothers in the Alliance. We can exchange information.”

Jack winced a little.

“We should be more cautious,” Sha're spoke up. “We don't know anything about them. They could be a danger to us.”

Frosta frowned at her. “They're fighting the Goa'uld - our enemies.”

“That doesn't mean that they're our allies,” Sha're retorted. “Or that they aren't willing to stab us in the back.”

“Indeed.” Teal'c nodded.

“It would be prudent to take the possibility into account that they have chosen a similar course as, ah, Hordak did when he was cut off from Horde Prime,” Daniel added with an apologetic smile.

“Yes.” Catra nodded sharply. “We need to know why they are fighting the Goa'uld before we make contact. If they want to conquer the galaxy in Horde Prime's name, we can't trust them.”

“They would consider us traitors,” WrongHordak said.

“But if we spy on them before contacting them, they might think we're not honest with them,” Perfuma objected. “We can't expect them to trust us if we aren't willing to extend our trust to them.”

Jack had to suppress another wince.

“We don't trust them,” Mermista said. “That's the point of this meeting. We need to decide what to do about them because they're acting weird and are a potential threat to us all.”

Perfuma frowned. “But is that our decision to make in the first place? Shouldn't we leave that either to the Alliance as a whole, or to the Horde, since they are their brothers, and not to the Princess Alliance?”

Good questions, Jack had to admit. This seemed to be a matter for the Alliance Command Council.

“Technically, this is both an internal matter for the Horde and a matter for the entire Alliance due to the threat a hostile Horde force represents,” Hordak said. “But since the majority of the clones follow She-Ra, she would have to be involved anyway, and since everyone knows Adora relies on her friends for advice, it seemed most efficient to have this meeting here to decide our course of action before informing the rest of the Alliance.”

Jack didn't like the implied dismissal of the Alliance as a whole, but the clone was correct. Whether Earth liked it or not, this would be decided by the clones and She-Ra. And, if he was honest, it was probably more productive as well. And, of course, he trusted Adora more than he trusted most of the governments back on Earth.

He leaned forward and focused on Adora. “So… What do you think?”

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What do I think? Adora briefly bit her lower lip. She had pondered this ever since she had heard about the news. Well, she could start with the easy part.

“I think this is a decision for the clones. Those were their brothers, their people. We don't know if the clones in that fleet still feel like they are part of the Horde or if they feel that they - or the fleets here - are a different people now that Horde Prime is

gone, like the others we've found before. But until we know, this is a Horde matter first, an Alliance matter second." Just as deciding to grow the clone population had been a Horde decision, not an Alliance decision.

"Should be good enough for the Alliance to accept so they can save face," Jack commented.

Catra snorted but didn't make any comment about letting an enemy save as much face as possible but nothing else. She'd done that last night already, of course.

"It's not an excuse," Daniel said. "It's the truth. And I doubt that the Earth countries want to set a precedent that would allow the Alliance to intervene in internal disputes."

"We absolutely would if it were necessary to save people," Glimmer muttered.

That was true, of course, but Adora was aware that it was best if they never had to do that.

"Internal disputes in a NATO country don't exactly present a threat to the Alliance as a whole," Jack said. "A Horde Fleet, though, does - they're what, a third of the current fleet strength?"

"That depends on whether or not they have maintained their ship numbers," Hordak replied. "They could have lost ships to battles and desertions. Or internal fighting. Or they could have increased their numbers, as we're doing."

"Do we even know if all Horde Fleets had the same number of ships?" Mermista asked. "We still don't know how many fleets existed thanks to Horde Prime keeping information from everyone, even the clones."

"All three Fleets with Horde Prime had the same number of ships," WrongHordak told her. "While not definite proof, it's pretty indicative of the norm."

“As obsessed as he was with what he saw as ‘perfect order’, the odds that he would have allowed divergences in the Horde's roster are minimal,” Hordak said with a sneer.

Adora agreed with that assessment. She couldn't see Horde Prime tolerating varying numbers of ships in his fleet.

“We should hope that they have the same number,” Catra said.

“Why?” Daniel looked puzzled.

“If they have lost significant numbers of ships to battle, it means there's an enemy out there who can match them - and us, in that case,” Catra explained. “If they destroyed each other over internal disputes, they might try to do the same to us.”

“That they do loot the false gods' resources and make determined attempts to salvage their ships might indicate that they have lost part or all of their fleet train and depend on such means to maintain and replenish their strength,” Teal'c speculated.

Adora nodded again. That was a possible explanation. The Horde didn't have bases to support their fleets. Each fleet carried their own logistical base with them, and if they lost it, they would be left to wither on the vine, so to speak. But…

“If they have access to even part of their fleet train, they should, over time, be able to restore it completely,” Hordak said. “Like First Fleet.”

“They would still have a problem with crewing new ships, though,” WrongHordak said. “Unless a lot of the crews of the lost ships survived their destruction - or were deployed on a planet at the time.”

First Fleet had drawn most of their replacement crews from the ground forces of Horde Prime that had been trapped on Etheria when Adora had turned his flagship - and with it the cloning pods - into a plant. But those had mostly come from the Velvet Glove; a

Fleet wouldn't have as many ground forces to deploy in the first place. “Could they build cloning pods?”

“Well, they should,” Entrapta said. “The basic design isn't that difficult to replicate, even without the blueprints in the databanks. Horde Prime really should have backed up his data.”

“In theory, they could,” Hordak added. “We all knew the basics. But whether or not any of the clones developed the aptitude to build such technology?” He shrugged. “I could have done it, but I was an aberration.”

“You're not an aberration. You're Hordak!” Entrapta told him with a frown.

He smiled at her, and Entrapta’s frown melted away.

Next to Adora, Catra snorted, but softly, so none but Adora heard it.

“In any case, I didn't have access to the mental patterns Horde Prime imprinted on every clone he grew,” Hordak went on. “And without them, the best I could have done would have been to copy my own. Which I did not want to. For various reasons.”

Adora nodded. She didn't want to pry. “So, the new fleet might be unable to replace lost clones.”

“Or they copied each other and formed some hive mind,” Catra joked. At least, Adora hoped she was joking. Judging by Entrapta and Sam’s expression, and Bow's grimace, Catra's idea might not be as absurd as it sounded.

“Let's hope not. Taking out hive minds is a pain,” Jack said. “But we still don't know how we deal with this new Horde force. Spy on them? Talk to them? Send them a late Valentine’s card?”

That was the tricky question. Adora looked at Hordak and WrongHordak. Maybe she should have invited Priest to this meeting as well, but… she already knew he would want them to

convert the other clones to worshipping Adora. Like he wanted to convert everyone else.

“We should be cautious and gather more information,” Hordak said. “Then, when we know more about them, decide how to handle them.”

WrongHordak shook his head. “We should approach them openly and arrange a meeting so we can honestly take their measure.”

Everyone was looking at her, Adora realised. Waiting for her decision. Well, this was easy. “We want friends we can trust, and that requires extending trust to them first.” She firmly nodded. “Honesty is the best policy.”

Of course, Catra had to snort and say something about “trust, but verify.”

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Orbit Above Etheria, April 19th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter had expected Adora's decision - anyone who knew her had. Or should have; she was sure some people back on Earth still didn't understand Adora. Probably because they were so cynical - or corrupt - they couldn't contemplate, much less accept that true idealists not only were real but also successful. It would wreck their worldview.

And it wasn't as if Adora's decision was wrong. Spying on the Horde fleet in question before contacting them might appear to be the cautious choice, but only if they weren't caught. If exposed, it would run the risk of antagonising the Horde force and spoiling any attempt at diplomacy. As much as some people might agree with the idea that a country had no friends, only interests, the fact was that countries were ruled by people, and people held grudges.

Still, being open and honest didn't mean you had to be careless about it. Adora was an idealist, but no fool. However, there was a

bit of a disagreement about what kind of preparations were adequate for the contact mission.

“We should take the entire First Fleet,” Hordak grumbled from where he was studying a screen on the bridge of the flagship First Fleet. “A show of force that will discourage aggression on the part of this Horde fleet. Unlike the other Horde remnants we met before, they are not only fighting battles, but they are not even just defending themselves or their territory; they’re actively attacking Goa'uld fleets and bases. If we appear weak, they might attack us as well.”

“We don't know that - we don't know why they're attacking the Goa'uld,” Entrapta pointed out. “If we appear threatening, they might attack us out of fear. It's a common response amongst many species. Including sapient ones, according to my data. We cannot expect them to act rationally.”

The General would say that sometimes, attacking when threatened was the rational response. Sam didn't disagree. But whether or not this applied to a specific situation was often only obvious in hindsight. She checked the data analysis her computer was running against the records from the spy bot network. So far, there were no irregularities.

“If they are so far gone as to let fear dictate their actions, they are already a threat that we would have to deal with sooner or later,” Hordak retorted. He shook his head. “And worse, if we show up with a fleet train, even parts of it, in tow, and they lack one, as we considered, then they might be tempted to attack us to take it from us.”

“We are not taking a fleet train with us on the contact mission,” Sam said. “Just a single yardship.” Enough to maintain the task force being sent for a short mission but nothing more. And none of the mining and refining and other supply ships that were necessary to provide sufficient logistics for a Horde fleet. “If we took the entire First Fleet, we would have to take the entire fleet train as well.”

“But we would have the strength to defend it,” Hordak argued. After a pause, he scowled. “I don't like this. All the other remnants we met, at least those who refused to join us, were isolationists. They refuse to accept that Horde Prime is gone and wait for orders that will never come, merely defending themselves when attacked. This fleet, though, shows initiative. They are conducting what seems to be an offensive - or at least a raiding campaign. Why are they doing this when all the others are passive?”

“Maybe they have a leader like you?” Entrapta smiled.

Hordak didn't. He grimaced. “That would be the worst case.”

Entrapta gasped. “Don't say that!”

Sam pressed her lips together for a moment. It wouldn't be fair to agree with Hordak. “You're not bent on conquest anymore,” she said instead.

“It took me many years and many experiences to change. And it was only possible because I was isolated from Horde Prime. I was formed by the unique circumstances I experienced on Etheria. The other clones were under his rule until a few years ago. They never had any freedom to develop their own opinions. They never had the opportunity to experience a different life, hear different opinions or act on their own initiative - that would have made Horde Prime cull them.” He shook his head. “No, if they have a leader like me, he'll be like me when I arrived on Etheria: Bent on conquest in Horde Prime's name.”

“We can’t know that!” Entrapta protested.

They couldn't. But It was very likely, in Sam's opinion. After Horde Prime had controlled every part of their life including their very thoughts, individuality came slowly to many clones.

“We need to be prepared for the worst,” Hordak said. “At the very least, we need to move the rest of First Fleet forward to a position where they can support and relieve us when necessary. Besides,

moving them out of the system will make the Princess Alliance stop complaining about the mining ships cracking asteroids. As if we're significantly reducing the number of asteroids! We could crack dozens without making even a hint of a dent!" he grumbled.

Sam knew that there was also a dispute about asteroid mining on Earth. The Horde fleet trains used to crack entire - smaller - asteroids for refining. It was quite effective but required large mining and refining ships and destroyed the asteroids being mined. The latter was a point of contention on Earth, especially amongst astronomers. Last she heard, there was talk about founding a society for the protection of celestial bodies.

Well, that was none of her concern. She was busy with research and the war effort. Which meant helping Entrapta and Hordak with planning the route to the new Horde fleet's area of operations.

She'd leave diplomacy and protecting asteroids to others.

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Gate Area, PZ-9771, April 30th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Alright! Drop it down here! Well, not drop - put it down, I meant."

"Sorry!"

"Don't worry. That will buff out."

Catra snorted and shook her head as Adora took a step back from the Stargate on the floor inside the shuttle, and Entrapta and Sam stared at their scanners.

"I just followed orders." Adora pouted at her.

"You should have known better. Fortunately, a Stargate is hard to break, even for you."

"Yes."

Just when Adora perked up, Catra added: “Much easier to break a shuttle.”

“It's not broken!”

Catra shrugged. “Not for lack of trying.”

Before Adora could reply to that, Entrapat stood up and nodded. “Alright! Everything's in order - we can fly off and return to the others! And install the Stargate on Hordak's flagship!”

“Finally!” In Catra's opinion, they should have installed Stargates on every fleet's flagship long ago, probably on a few more. It would make moving around between theatres of operation much faster for everyone. But that meant removing them from planets, and between planets with a population and planets with the potential for being settled, finding Stargates no one would miss had been a bit of a challenge. You had to thoroughly check whether a planet really didn't have a native population, and that usually required more than a quick trip through the Stargate and a look at the gate area.

But this planet's population had been wiped out in the war between Horde Prime and the First Ones, at least according to the records they had recovered in the remains. Probably as collateral damage, Catra thought - neither side had really cared about anyone else. So, no one would miss this Stargate. And they really needed a mobile one in this sector, what with this weird Horde force being active in the area.

The ramp closed behind her, and she took a seat next to Adora's just before the shuttle lifted off. Shortly afterwards, escorted by a squadron of Horde fighters, they entered orbit and approached the frigate serving as flagship of this task force.

Hordak was already waiting in the hangar, and Catra and Adora stepped out of the way as he, Entrapta and Sam got busy moving and installing the Stargate. Catra followed Adora to the bridge. There was nothing they could do to help with that except for

doing the heavy lifting, but they could adjust the gravity for that here, and there would be reports waiting for the Supreme Commander of the Alliance on the bridge.

There always were reports and other paperwork waiting for Adora.

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Outside PT-9621 System, May 1st, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We've sent the communication request, Commander," the clone crewman reported to Hordak. "No response yet."

Catra hadn't expected an immediate response. Being contacted out of the blue, by First Fleet - the escort force for Horde Prime's flagship? That would have surprised, maybe shocked the clones in the system.

On the other hand, all the scattered Horde forces they had contacted before had quickly, sometimes desperately asked them if they had news about Horde Prime. She checked the time. Almost a minute, and this force had yet to open a channel.

"The ships inside the system are moving into a defensive formation."

Catra could see that on the holoprojection.

"Well, they didn't miss our call," Jack commented.

"They're not wary but not aggressive," Adora said.

"They don't know our forces," Hordak retorted. "This is a standard reaction. Once they know our numbers, they might alter their formation depending on their intentions."

"Incoming call."

Adora straightened. "Put it on the screen."

A clone appeared on the screen. He didn't look any different compared to any other clones. Same appearance, standard uniform. Just like Horde Prime had wanted. And yet… Catra narrowed her eyes. Something was off.

"Hello!" Adora beamed at the clone. "I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. This is Hordak, the commander of First Fleet."

Catra and the others present stayed outside the field of view of the communicator. Honesty might be the best policy, but that didn't mean you had to tell an unknown force everything right away. Explaining the Alliance would take some time, anyway. Especially the difference between the Goa'uld and the Tok'Ra. And the difference between Earth and the First Ones.

The Horde clone frowned a little at Hordak, Catra noted. Was he offended by his appearance? Some clones considered any change to their bodies an aberration, a violation of Horde Prime's will.

"I am the Commander of the Horde."

That was quite the claim if he meant the entire Horde. And it seemed he knew that Horde Prime was gone. Otherwise, he'd have asked the supposed leader of First Fleet about it. But had he no name, or was he hiding his name? Catra couldn't tell. And yet, something was definitely off about the clone. Something… She stepped over to Entrapta. "Can you zoom in on him on your screen?" she whispered.

"Yes!"

"What do you want?" the clone asked.

Catra focused on his appearance. The uniform was the same, but… "His shoulders!" she whispered.

"What about it?" Jack asked in a low voice.

Catra leaned over and zoomed in further. "Look at the shoulders! Beneath the cape! Something left a mark on it there. Something

heavy.” Those marks looked like the dents in a Horde uniform's shoulder pads after wearing a heavy backpack for hours - something Catra was familiar with as a punishment. “He must have been wearing something else on his shoulders and has replaced it with the standard clone cape to talk to us.”

“Yes?” Entrapta looked confused.

But Jack nodded. “He's hiding something.”

It was just a feeling, but Catra was pretty sure it was something important.

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The Clones Question Part 3

Outside PT-9621 System, May 1st, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We have made contact with you so we can find out what your intentions are, Commander."

While Adora spoke to the 'Commander of the Horde', Jack O'Neill studied his image on the screen to the side, out of the field of view of the camera. It wouldn't do to let those clones know that Etheria and Hordak were working with Earth. Honesty was all good and well, but you didn't have to be stupid about it.

And Catra had been correct - the clothes of this 'Commander' showed signs of something heavy he had been wearing on his shoulders. Though it wasn't a backpack. The position wasn't right for that. Unless it was some weird alien-style backpack - but the bodies of clones were so close to humans, that would have had to be a rather inconvenient setup for them. And while Jack had never met Horde Prime himself, his impression was that the megalomaniac wouldn't have settled for anything short of perfect for his clones.

On the other hand, the outfits weren't exactly practical.

"You wish to know our intentions?" The Clone Commander - Jack made a note to sneak in a G.I. Joe reference sometime - sounded suspicious.

Adora, though, merely smiled widely. "Yes. You're fighting the Goa'uld, after all."

"You know about them?"

Definitely suspicious. Although… should he have expected that, since they were meeting in a system that was, if not a frontline system, as far as you could have a frontline in space, so very close to it?

“We’re First Fleet,” Hordak spoke up. “We are aware of many things Horde Prime did keep from other fleets.”

“You claim to be First Fleet. I do not see the Velvet Glove with you. And I do not recognise you.”

“He must know that Horde Prime is dead,” Daniel commented on the obvious in a low voice. “He didn’t ask about him.”

“The Velvet Glove was lost when Horde Prime died,” Hordak said. “As were many ships. But we have rebuilt, and now we are stronger than before.”

The Commander stared at him, and Jack caught the hint of a sneer on his face. *“How did Horde Prime die?”*

“He attacked me and my friends,” Adora cut in. “He tried to conquer us, and we defeated him.”

“Who are you?”

“I am She-Ra, Princess of Power. Protector of Etheria,” Adora replied.

Glimmer scoffed. "He's rude to make her repeat herself."

The Commander’s eyes flicked to the side, staring at Hordak. *“And you follow her?”*

Hordak slowly inclined his head. “Horde Prime tried to erase me. He failed.”

The Commander nodded. *“He was not fit to lead us.”*

Jack wasn’t the only one to be surprised - he heard a couple of gasps so loud, the microphones on the bridge would have picked them up if not for the filtering software Carter had installed.

“None of the other fleets we found rejected Horde Prime like that,” Daniel whispered.

“If they rejected Horde Prime and are fighting the Goa’uld…” Glimmer trailed off, but her hopeful tone clearly showed what she was thinking.

“The enemy of my enemy is the enemy of my enemy,” Jack muttered. Those were the same guys who had wiped out entire worlds and species for their leader. And unlike the clones in the Alliance, they hadn’t seen Horde Prime fall and then were welcomed by the princesses and turned into allies.

“Yes. He was cruel, arrogant and treated you like tools,” Adora said, nodding firmly. “You deserve better than that. Everyone does.”

“So, what are your goals here?” Hordak asked. “Why are you fighting the Goa’uld?”

"You ask about our goals, yet hide your own.”

“We have been rebuilding our numbers, and now we’re working to restore what was lost in the war,” Hordak said.

Like magic, Jack thought, clenching his teeth for a moment.

“We’re looking for allies,” Adora added. “And for threats to us.”

“And do you think we are such a threat?”

“That depends on your intentions - and on your reason to fight the Goa’uld,” Adora replied.

Well, that was obvious to anyone, in Jack’s opinion.

"We are fighting the Goa’uld System Lords because they are unworthy leaders like Horde Prime.”

“And who is your leader?” Adora asked.

“I lead the Horde.”

Jack frowned. That was…

“He’s evasive,” Daniel said.

“Does that mean you claim power over all Horde remnants?” Hordak asked.

“That depends on your intentions.” The Commander’s lips twisted into a brief smile.

Smug bastard, Jack thought.

“You know our intentions,” Hordak retorted. He made a point to look at Adora. “We follow She-Ra. She has proven to be a leader worthy of respect. Someone who cares and protects her people. And she has defeated Horde Prime in single combat.”

Jack winced. That was throwing down the gauntlet - all that was missing was a direct challenge.

“I see.” The Commander stared at her. “Are you a First One?”

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Adora suppressed a wince. That was a difficult question. She didn’t want to lie - omitting the truth was bad enough already - but the Alliance had gone to great lengths to make Apophis think that Hordak was fighting the First Ones and their descendants. And since this fleet was fighting the Goa’uld, what were the odds that they were aware of that bit of intel? Or that they would become aware of it?

So she smiled and said: “I was born a First One but was taken as a baby from them and raised in the Horde under Hordak.”

For the first time, the Commander seemed obviously surprised. *“What? You were raised in the Horde? By Hordak? Who follows you now? A First One?”*

Ah… Adora saw Catra shake her head outside the camera’s field of view.

“There were no First Ones left except me,” Adora said. “They tried to destroy our world, Etheria.”

“I was stranded on Etheria decades ago,” Hordak said. “I gathered what forces and resources I could to conquer the world - for Horde Prime. And yet, when I was returned to the fold, I was judged a mistake to be fixed.”

“And we took him in,” Adora said. “We protect our world from any threat, whether it might be the Horde or the First Ones.” She stared at the Commander.

He inclined his head in return. *“And you wish to know if we are such a threat.”*

“As we told you already.” Adora resisted the temptation to roll her eyes. And ignored that Catra did roll hers.

“You defeated Horde Prime - or so you claim - and then took over First Fleet. Are you here to attempt to take us over as well?”

“We are not here to take over anyone,” Adora explained, clenching her teeth for a moment. Why did people always assume the worst of her and her friends? “We did not take over the Horde either. We welcomed them as new allies whom Horde Prime had hurt as much as he had hurt us, even if many had not realised it before he was finally defeated.” The clones might not have had the same chips Catra and the others had suffered from, but they had been as tightly controlled, bound to Horde Prime’s whims.

“So, you claim you are a worthy leader,” the Commander said after a moment.

“Yes.” Adora nodded firmly. She wasn’t perfect, but she tried her best. And that had to count for something. There were certainly many worse leaders.

“Yes, she has proven her mettle,” Hordak agreed.

Adora managed not to glance at him in response. He could just be playing his role, but… Later. "People follow us out of their own free will." In some cases even against her wishes. "We're here to check up on you, nothing more. We are not here to recruit you."

"So you claim."

"What can we do to prove that to you?" Adora asked. That was the heart of the matter.

"A demonstration of the power with which you defeated Horde Prime to prove that claim," he replied at once.

That would be… difficult. She couldn't exactly replicate the circumstances of Horde Prime's defeat. She could restore a planet's magic and use the power for an impressive display of magic, though.

She noticed that Catra was glaring at her and mouthing 'no'. But this was an opportunity to convince the Commander that they were speaking the truth about Horde Prime. "Pick a planet nearby, and I can show you my power." She blinked and quickly added: "I will not destroy it or render it uninhabitable."

The Commander looked at her for a moment - was he surprised by her accepting his offer - or challenge? Then he nodded. *"As you wish. I shall contact you with a suitable location soon."*

The connection cut, and the screen turned black.

Adora sighed, smiling. "That went well." Better than she had feared.

"So, we're showing off magic to them?" Jack asked.

"Apophis and anyone with spies in his court already know about magic after the battle in front of his palace," Hordak retorted.

"Not the point. But what if this is a trap? We're giving them time to mass more ships," Catra said.

“We also have time to prepare,” Glimmer retorted. “And Adora can turn their ships into plants if she has to.”

“Ah…” Adora wasn’t sure she could do that with the magic of a single planet. And she hadn’t really planned to do it, back then.

“Guys!” Daniel spoke up before she could explain that. “About the clone’s clothes…”

As everyone turned to look at him, Sha’re took a step forward. “Those marks fit what an Usekh leaves if you wear it constantly over the same clothes.”

Adora frowned. Usekh?

“That’s the ornamental collar many Goa’uld and Jaffa wear,” Daniel said.

“Indeed.”

Oh…

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Marks from an ornamental collar? Samantha Carter was not an expert on Goa'uld fashion. She was a physicist, not an anthropologist. But Sha're had years of experience living as a host, and Teal'c had spent decades in Apophis's service. She trusted them.

“If this fleet is under a System Lord’s command, and if Apophis has a spy at their court, then She-Ra being allied with First Fleet will have revealed our ruse about the Horde fighting Earth,” Hordak said.

“If Apophis had spies who knew about the Horde fleet here, I think we would have heard about it already - it’s a threat he wouldn’t ignore, and he would inform the other System Lords about it,” Catra retorted.

“Of course, the clones here following a Goa’uld is merely a hypothesis. There are other possible explanations for those marks,” Daniel said. “And many cultures had similar ornamental collars.”

Sam could tell that he did believe Sha're's guess - and Teal'c's - was correct, though. She did as well.

As did the General. He nodded. “If those clones are working for the snakes, then having our ruse revealed is the least of our problems…”

Sam nodded. Goa’uld with access to Horde technology were a much more dangerous enemy. Combined with the resources of their Empire…

“We don't know that,” Daniel repeated himself. “Even if the Commander has been wearing an Usekh, it doesn't mean he's following a Goa'uld - he could have looted such a collar and worn it as a trophy.”

“He was trying to hide it from us, though,” the General pointed out.

“He had no information about us. If First Fleet had stayed true to Horde Prime's ideal, wearing such clothes could be seen as corruption by them,” Daniel said.

“Horde Prime definitely wouldn't have tolerated that amongst his clones,” Hordak said. “He had clones disposed of for much smaller divergences from his chosen template.”

He knew from personal experience, Sam reminded herself.

“At least we know he's not a host. We do know that, right?” The General looked at her.

“Clones, like the Asgard from which they are descended, reject the symbionts,” Sam confirmed. “Trying to possess one would be fatal over time.”

“And he has no mark on his forehead,” the General went on. “So, he's not a First Prime.”

“He might not have yet served loyally long enough to have earned that reward,” Teal'c said.

Sam knew that that didn't mean the Commander wasn't as fanatically loyal, though. Priest and his followers were the best example. And new converts were, usually, more fanatical than older members of a religion.

“If the fleet's serving a System Lord, it would explain why they're looting and salvaging Goa'uld resources and ships,” Catra said. “They would have Jaffa serving him who can use the loot.”

“Yes.” Sha're nodded. “And turning a Horde Fleet on their rival System Lords would allow them to hide their actions and avoid retribution. They might even plan to use this ‘threat’ to form an alliance with their rivals only to betray them at the most opportune moment.”

“But who could be doing this?” Glimmer asked. “It can't be Apophis or he would have sent the Horde against his rivals - and against us.”

“Every System Lord would do this if they could,” Sha're said. “And any of their underlings would defect in a heartbeat and try to take over themselves if they managed to take over a Horde Fleet.”

“They would have become one of the most powerful Goa'uld at once,” Teal'c said. “Though they would also drive the others to unite against them, should they be exposed.”

Adora shook her head. “If they're following a Goa'uld System in the first place - we don't know that for sure.”

“I think we can safely dismiss the claim that they’re fighting the snakes because they hate such leaders,” the General said. “The Commander was far too shifty to be an idealist.”

“The other clones might be, though. It wouldn't be the first time that a leader is manipulating their followers by using their beliefs and claiming to share them,” Daniel retorted.

“The False Gods have been using that ploy for thousands of years,” Teal'c said. “Although they would not tolerate such cynicism from their warriors.”

“They do expect it from the Goa'uld serving them,” Sha're retorted.

“And some of the snakes might buy into their own lies,” the General commented. “They're certainly arrogant enough to think they're gods.”

“Can we convert them?” Bow asked. “Like Priest converted?”

Adora looked torn, Sam noted. But others nodded.

“Seeing She-Ra's power would impress anyone,” Glimmer said. “We know some of the most loyal Jaffa have converted after seeing her.”

“And after fighting her,” Catra added.

“It is worth a try,” Hordak agreed. “Unlike the Goa'uld, Adora does not need to fake her powers with technology. Nor does she rely on blind faith without any supporting evidence like Earth religions.”

That wasn't entirely correct, as far as Sam understood things - she hadn't done any actual research into the matter, but the reports of spirits manifesting on Earth following the return of magic had an influence on religions that worshipped such spirits. Like Shinto. Though Daniel expected at least some established religions, even monotheistic ones, to adapt their dogma as well, or so he had said a bit ago.

But this wasn't the time to discuss religion. Not that she wanted to discuss religion at any time if she could help it.

Glimmer nodded. “Should we call in Priest then? He can use the Stargate to join us.”

“We need reinforcements as well. First Fleet is the closest, but we probably can't stall long enough for them to reach us before the demonstration,” Catra said, frowning at Adora. “So, we also need to plan how to handle the Commander betraying us.”

She seemed quite sure that such an attempt would be made, Sam noted. And she wasn't the only one. The General and Hordak agreed as well.

And Sam couldn't disagree. Not with the information they had.

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Outside PT-9497 System, May 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra had to hand it to the Commander (whom she really had to give a nickname or something; “Commander” sounded far too pretentious to her): He had picked this system well. It was close enough to reach it in a few hours in a Horde ship, but further away from former Horde space than the system in which they made contact. That meant the rest of First Fleet couldn't reach them in time for the ‘demonstration’.

Not only that, but, as their scanners and spreading spy bots showed, the other fleet had had additional forces close enough to reach the system, which meant the task force was now even more outnumbered. Worse, those reinforcements were trying to hide, staying out of range of the standard sensors of the Horde frigates.

“This is a trap,” she said, pointing at the holoprojection on the bridge that showed the system and the surrounding space, including the two Horde flotillas in question.

“We don't know that,” Adora retorted. “The Commander could have called them as reinforcements in case we ambushed them.” Catra cocked her head and raised her eyebrows at her idiot of a lover, and Adora flushed before raising her chin a little in that

endearing stubborn way of hers. “It's a possibility. We would do the same and we don't plan to betray them.”

Catra snorted. “I've been planning various preemptive strikes ever since we've set out for this system.” She hadn't managed to come up with any that she liked, though - and those reinforcements had rendered all plans with halfway decent chances of success obsolete.

“I know,” Adora replied. “But you weren't planning to betray them from the start. This is just a contingency if they betray us.”

“Well, it sure looks like they want to ambush us,” Jack commented.

“They're staying back, though - they're not moving to encircle us, for example,” Daniel objected.

“Those two forces could reach us in minutes through hyperspace,” Catra pointed out. “If they want to encircle us, they can exit hyperspace behind us.” Of course, they would have to plot their course when they were still minutes away, which meant they could only drop from hyperspace in close range if their targets were stationary or at least in predictable orbits. Or fixed in place by the force meeting them openly.

And the latter tactic was quite difficult to pull off in a battle, especially if your enemy just wanted to get away and was ready to sacrifice a rear guard to hold your forces while the rest escaped. Which meant that Catra was pretty confident that the Commander was planning an ambush without warning. They could spoil that by keeping their task force moving around the system in random order, but that would tip him off that they knew or at least suspected his treachery.

She shrugged. “So, do we want to bait him into attacking us by staying stationary, or do we tell him we know what he's planning by staying on the move while we’re in the system?”

Jack snorted. “If we had the entire First Fleet here, I'd say bait him into dropping the facade and attacking us, then turn the tables on him and counter-ambush them.”

“That would put everyone in the task force at risk,” Adora protested.

“They'd still be safer than we will be on the planet's surface,” Catra pointed out. “Even with a stealth shuttle.” If the other fleet could move enough frigates to start a saturation bombardment, things would get tricky. Even stealth shuttles could be hit by firing blindly.

Her lover frowned at her, and Catra flashed her fangs in return. Did Adora think she would let her go down on the planet by herself?

“I doubt they will attack, if they're planning to turn on us in the first place, before Adora has demonstrated her powers,” Daniel said. “They want to know what they are facing.”

“They could also just want to decapitate our forces,” Catra retorted, clenching her teeth. She'd rather not bet Adora's life on the Commander wanting more intel.

Sha're shook her head. “If they are serving a System Lord, they will want to know more about Adora's power - as much as possible, actually, since they will want to know if they can take it for themselves. They won't risk losing out on such a prize by striking too soon and killing her.”

That did sound exactly how the snakes thought. Catra could see whoever took over a Horde fleet trying to gain more power from their enemies. Of course, that just made it less likely that the Commander would play it first and try to kill them right away, not impossible. And once the demonstration was finished…

“But once they know it's magic, they will know they cannot take it for themselves,” Glimmer pointed out.

Catra nodded. “And they will try to kill us to deny this to anyone else.”

“And to stop us from using it against them,” Hordak added.

“Only those of them who reject the evidence of their own eyes - and sensors - and deny Her Divine Might,” Priest spoke up. “As in the past, Her Holy Deeds will enlighten even Her enemies and show them a better way.”

Judging by the way Adora flinched, she regretted calling Priest to join them through the Stargate on the flagship. But it was good to have Priest here - he brought a different perspective.

“As nice as it would be to have the entire enemy fleet convert to worshipping She-Ra, I don't think we can count on that,” Jack said. “It never worked so far.”

“Many converted to Her faith after seeing the truth of Her Divine power, wisdom and mercy themselves,” Priest retorted. “That others remain blind and determined to fight the truth does not change that.”

“Despite a number of deserters, and likely more who keep their change of allegiance secret, the bulk of Apophis's warriors remain loyal to the false god,” Teal'c said. “It would be reckless to expect otherwise here.”

Catra nodded. Adora changing a planet with her magic might impress the clones, but enough to change allegiance? She doubted that. Most Jaffa they knew to have converted had experienced a much more personal encounter with Adora's power, having fought her and then were healed by her.

No, she was quite sure they couldn't count on that to win the day here. They would have to win using their wits and guts, as Jack would put it.

And time was running short - the Commander expected them to enter the system now.

Fortunately, Catra had some ideas ready.

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Orbit above PT-9497, May 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Having his own stealth shuttle had a number of perks. One of them being the most experienced stealth shuttle pilot in the task force, which meant Jack O'Neill was a shoo-in for the ‘contingency mission’ everyone but the most optimist worshipper of Her Divine Highness She-Ra knew would be necessary to counter the Commander's imminent betrayal.

Well, even if he weren't the best choice as pilot, he would have been on the shuttle anyway - since SG-1 was kind of famous, or infamous, amongst the snakes, they couldn't go down to the surface with Adora and the others, and staying back on the bridge of the task force's flagship wasn't Jack's thing - he was Special Ops, not Navy. And any advice he might be able to give to Hordak he could as well do over the communicator.

An argument that had the drawback of also applying to Daniel and Sha're, who were on the shuttle as well, together with Carter and Teal'c, but you couldn't win them all. Besides, it wouldn't feel right to go on dangerous missions to foil the plans of evil aliens without his best friends at his back.

And speaking of friends… He pushed the button of the intercom. “Hello everyone! This is your pilot speaking. After sneaking into this system, we've arrived at our destination and entered a holding pattern. So far, we haven't been cleared to land, so please be patient and ready to disembark on short notice.”

“Jack…” Daniel complained from behind him, but he heard Sha're giggle, once, and Carter would likely be hiding a smile as well.

Time to double down! “Please check the entertainment system for the local news!”

“The delegation hasn't landed yet, sir,” Carter reported.

He could see that on his screen - the shuttle, a regular model, carrying Adora, Glimmer and Bow down to the surface was still approaching the planet, and the First Fleet's task force had taken a formation in high orbit that should discourage a surprise attack by enemies dropping in from hyperspace - the odds of hitting the planet when coming out of hyperspace were a bit too high. Not that it would be a surprise, anyway; they had eyes on the enemy flotillas outside the system and would be alerted at once should they start to move.

“I should be on the shuttle,” Catra complained from the rear.

“Sorry, catwomen are a bit too distinctive,” Jack told her, turning to grin over his shoulder.

“So's She-Ra. Everyone saw her on Saqqara,” Catra retorted.

“But she’s already known.” Jack shrugged. In hindsight, they shouldn’t have revealed Adora like that. Jaffa were worshipping She-Ra, which meant news of her was spreading alongside her faith among Apophis's warriors and slaves. Any spy could hear about her. But Adora hadn't wanted to use a fake name. Honesty and all.

Still, that didn’t mean they had to reveal Catra as well. She had been a bit more noticeable during the covert part of the mission on Saqqara, when they had been passing themselves off as a delegation bringing tribute - including her. An unknown alien species? That had been noticed, and the guards and servants at Apophis's Stargate and palace hadn't been distracted by a fight for their survival at the time either. “Athletic blonde women are not that uncommon.” Athletic blonde women who could do magic, on the other hand… well, that ship had sailed already.

“Yes! Athletic blonde women are very common on Earth, as our data indicates! Even more common than their genes’ spread amongst your population would indicate, actually!” Entrapta chimed in. “And Glimmer can only teleport two people with her.”

“I should have taken Bow's place,” Catra hissed.

She could have, but Bow was the more experienced pilot. And he was a Techmaster, which Jack knew from long experience could come in very handy when things went sideways in unexpected ways, which they tended to do, in Jack's experience.

Not that he would say that out loud and trigger another argument - Catra was already too worried about Adora and the others. A sentiment Jack shared. The clone was going to stab them in the back; Jack's gut told him so, and every piece of intel they got confirmed it. The question was just when. Smart money was on ‘after Adora's demonstration’, but it was by no means certain. The Commander might also be waiting until she was in the middle of her demonstration, to attack while she was distracted.

Then again, attacking She-Ra in the middle of releasing a planet's worth of magic? There were far easier ways to commit suicide in Jack's experience. Hell, he was almost hoping the Commander would do that - he was curious if the clone frigates would end up as space plants in orbit.

“A shuttle has just left the other fleet's formation and is headed down to the planet's surface,” Carter reported. “Scans do not show any explosives on board.”

“Any bets that the Commander isn’t on it?” Jack asked.

“That's a sucker's bet,” Catra replied. “He'll send some expendable clones.”

“The other fleet isn't in a position to conduct an orbital bombardment of the meeting place,” Carter said.

“They're just a short flight away, though,” Entrapta commented.

On the screen, Jack could see that their own shuttle had touched down. A few more minutes, now.

He checked the enemy fleet. They were holding their positions opposite the task force. And the enemy shuttle was still on course. If the clones planned to crash it into Adora's shuttle, they would have to act now to hit it with enough force…

But the shuttle continued to brake, touching down about a hundred metres away from Adora's.

Jack nodded. "Showtime."

*****

PT-9497, May 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

Adora watched the Horde shuttle's ramp come down and straightened. Time to impress them and avoid a fight.

"Here they come," Glimmer commented from the shuttle where she was watching with Bow, as two clones disembarked, followed by four bots. All of them started walking toward Adora, throwing up dust with every step - the planet was mostly barren, with only primitive plants growing in spots.

"Based on the mass of the shuttle our scanners show, that only leaves the two crew inside," Bow added over the communicator. *"Unless they've altered the shuttle to reduce its mass to hide more people inside it. But that's a standard model, designed by Horde Prime himself, made for his clones and bots with minimal accommodations. To reduce its mass significantly would have taken a lot of effort."*

And Adora didn't think the clones would go that far just to hide a few more of their number. Not that it mattered.

"Thanks, Bow," Glimmer said. She sounded tense and impatient. *"More importantly, is the Commander amongst them?"*

"No," Adora replied.

"No," Bow confirmed a moment later.

"How can you tell without a scan? They all look alike," Glimmer asked. *"They haven't customised their appearance like our clones."*

"The way they move," Adora told her. And a gut feeling - she had been raised in the Horde, after all, which had been very big on having their soldiers look alike as much as possible, down to uniforms that hid as much of them as they could. And she had spent a lot of time with the clones after Horde Prime's death. Probably a bit too much, in hindsight.

"Hello," she called out, smiling, as the clones reached them. "Welcome."

The clones nodded at her in return, then stared at the shuttle behind her. The cockpit windows were polarised, so they wouldn't be able to see Adora's friends inside. Of course, if whoever was behind this fleet had access to Apophis's intel from Saqqara, that wouldn't help too much, but at least it couldn't harm. And Apophis had gone to great lengths to suppress knowledge of his humiliation there.

"So, who are you?" she asked.

The clones turned to stare at her. "We represent the Commander of the Horde," one of them said.

Adora was feeling a little annoyed at the implied claim, but she couldn't blame them for it; they didn't seem to have grown past their conditioning yet, unlike the clones in the Alliance. It seemed only the Commander had. "So, you're here to watch me demonstrate my power," she went on.

The clones nodded in unison, and Adora couldn't help remembering her first encounter with Horde Prime. All the clones, moving like parts of a machine, tools to be manipulated… Not if I can help it, she thought. And she would.

"So, watch. And don't worry - no matter how it looks, you're safe."

She took a step to the side and raised her sword. Taking a deep breath, she closed her eyes and focused on her power. She-Ra's magic. She felt the familiar pattern around her, barely restraining the planet's magic. She connected her own power to it, opened herself to the magic, and clenched her teeth as the magic rushed into her. As often as she had done this, it was still a struggle to hold it together, contain the magic, keep it from lashing out even as it felt as if she was about to burst herself, caught between the magic of this world and the pattern holding it back, trying to funnel it towards herself.

She slashed her blade down, cutting the pattern, and the magic was released in a blaze.

She opened her eyes and turned, looking at the clones, at the shuttles, at her friends, at the world, and channelled the magic into the world. Into the tiny plants and animals struggling to survive, into the water full of metals and other pollution, into the air dusty from smoke.

And she felt the world change as magic cleaned it and filled it with new life. New plants sprouting all over, growing rapidly, animals changing, spreading, evolving. Life changing from what was into what could have been. What would be, now.

The magic kept coming, wave after wave, changing the world. Finally, she felt the pressure vanish, stabilise, and shuddered as she lowered her sword.

The landscape around them had changed. No longer a practically barren, dusty plains, it was now a lush mix of forests and fields. She could hear birds sing and insects buzz around.

And she saw the clones gape at her, shocked and shivering.

“This is my power,” she told them.

“This is… this” one of them stammered, rubbing his arms.

“Not even Horde Prime could have done this!” the other exclaimed. “The whole world changed! You made it come alive!”

She nodded. “I told you the world wouldn't suffer. Quite the contrary.”

“This… this changes things,” the first said. “We have to tell the others.”

“Yes.” Adora smiled. It was working. They could avoid…

Before she could finish the thought, the bots jerked and raised their weapons. Adora changed her sword into a shield out of reflex, ready to block the blasts - but the bots shot the clones.

*****

Orbit above PT-9497, May 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Shots fired!” Samantha Carter announced.

“The enemy fleet is moving!” the General snapped.

Her eyes darted from the screen showing the magitech scanner's focus on the area on the planet's surface where Adora and the others were to the holographic display showing the planet's orbits and back. The General had the con. She trusted him and focused on the scene on the ground. This was the betrayal they had expected, So… Oh!

“The enemy bots shot the enemy clones,” she told the others. “She-Ra has destroyed them in return.”

“Bugout is a go, I repeat, Bugout is a go!” the General announced. “The enemy ships are moving into bombardment range. Get the hell out of there!”

Sam clenched her teeth and watched Adora check the clones before sprinting back to the shuttle. Even if the clones were still alive, they couldn't save them!

“Shuttle's taking off,” she reported, then glanced up to check the enemy fleet.

“Horde flotillas outside the system have entered hyperspace,” Entrapta said.

As expected, Sam thought.

“Noted.” Hordak sounded calm and collected on the comm. *“Moving to support Bugout.”*

Sam barely noticed the view through the windows changing as the General changed course and dove down into the atmosphere. Instead, she was focused on the shuttle's course below them. The first frigates were now coming within range of the task force as they tried to intercept the shuttle carrying Adora, Glimmer and Bow.

“Adora!” Catra snapped. “Get out now!”

The enemy frigates opened up, their fire split between the task force’s vanguard and the shuttle climbing up.

A moment later, she heard a faint pop and sparkles briefly lit up the shuttle's interior behind her. Glimmer had teleported in.

“Adora! You idiot!” Catra exclaimed.

“Hey! We were fine!”

And on Sam's screen, the shuttle blew up as several beams struck it.

“Bugout complete,” the General snapped. “Leaving atmosphere again.”

“Understood,” Hordak confirmed. *“Withdrawing.”*

Sam looked at the holoprojection and saw the task force's formation split up as the ships changed course and accelerated,

no longer flying directly at the enemy, but enveloping them as they sped past - a very dangerous manoeuvre as the enemy dense formation plunged directly into the former centre of the task force's. And at that close range, the fire would be murderous - already, Sam saw several ships on both sides getting hit, their shields flaring and failing.

But the Commander's fleet wasn't reacting quickly enough - the ships which had fired at the shuttle had fallen back and overcompensated, messing up the enemy formation. And they seemed to have trouble focusing their fire, Sam realised - unlike First Fleet's ships. By the time the enemy had restored their rough wedge formation, First Fleet's ships had savaged their outer flanks and were past them, reforming into a defensive formation while staying their course. Sam hadn't recorded any total loss on their side while one enemy frigate had blown up and another had lost all power.

More importantly, the enemy now had to either turn around while maintaining formation, which would slow them down considerably, or execute a much more complex manoeuvre where every ship turned individually and took a different place in a reformed formation.

They tried the latter despite multiple ships having suffered damage, and the slightly ragged formation was torn up completely. Two ships even collided, and more had near-misses that led to frantic course changes, which disrupted the formation even more.

"Reverse course and attack."

Hordak took advantage of it at once. The task force's ships all cut their engines, turned a hundred and eight degrees without changing their course, and then redlined their engines to quickly reverse their course - driving at the disrupted enemy fleet at an angle that cut straight through their right wing.

They were in close range before the enemy could reform, and their focused fire claimed half a dozen already damaged ships without suffering any total losses themselves before the fleet separated again.

“According to the spy bots’ data, the reinforcements for the Horde will arrive in a minute, Hordak,” Entrapta reported. “If our estimates are correct, which I think they are.”

“Noted.”

Thirty seconds later, while the enemy fleet was still rearranging their tattered formation, the task force entered hyperspace.

“Are you picking up any beacons from escape pods on our side?” the General asked.

The task force had not suffered any total loss, but Sam checked the sensor's results again before answering: “No, sir.”

“Check for enemy survivors!” the General ordered.

“Enemy flotillas dropping out of hyperspace! Aw, we didn't get their positions right!” Entrapta sounded disappointed.

While the scanner searched for survivors amongst the enemy wrecks, Sam quickly verified the positions of the reinforcements herself. They were further out than expected. And quite a bit off from the ideal positions they had calculated. Either they had overestimated the enemy - or the Commander had been a bit too confident and anticipated their response.

Either way, the new arrivals were no concern. “Tracking life signs in the closest wreck, sir,” Sam said. That was the enemy ship that had lost all power in the first exchange. And it was the furthest from any enemy formation.

“Good. Let's see if we can get a prisoner before we leave.” The General grinned. “Might as well save something from this, right?”

The safe course of action would be to leave the system as quickly as possible and then arrange a pickup outside with the task force, but Sam nodded. They needed more information about this fleet.

So, while the General moved the shuttle towards the enemy hulk, Sam and the others suited up and prepared to board the drifting frigate.

*****

PT-9497 System, May 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We don't have much time - two frigates are headed this way already. So, get in, grab someone and get out again!"

Catra snorted at Jack's comment. As if they wanted to stay any longer than needed in the enemy wreck. Adora had already risked her life doing that stupid stunt - and then doubled down and tried to save the lives of two enemies at the risk of her own! - there was no way Catra would let her risk her life pointlessly again!

"Docking."

She flexed her claws as she heard the sound of metal touching metal and felt the floor rock a little as the shuttle locked onto the frigate's hull.

"Opening!" Entrapta announced, and the door slid past, revealing the slightly scorched airlock of a Horde frigate.

Entrapta and Sam started working on the door controls at once, and half a minute later - far too long, in Catra's opinion! - the airlock opened.

She was the first through, followed by Adora, Glimmer and Bow. The airlock closed behind them, then air filled - the frigate had lost main power, but emergency systems were still working.

As soon as the inner door opened, she dashed through, glancing left and right. The engine room would be to the left, and any

damage control parties would be there, restoring the ship's power was the priority. Maybe…

Her ears twitched, and she grinned. “Someone's in the compartment next to us!”

A few swipes of her claws cut a hole in the wall in front of her, revealing a startled clone. Before he could react, Adora hat hit him over the head with the flat of her sword and knocked him out.

“Done. Returning!” Catra reported over the communicator.

Half a minute later, they were back in the shuttle.

“And we're leaving! Company's coming!” Jack announced as the shuttle undocked.

Catra was about to say something about an easy job when she heard a gasp. Turning, she saw that Sha're was kneeling next to the prisoner, holding up a small golden amulet that the clone must have been wearing under his uniform. It looked kind of familiar - definitely snake style - but she couldn’t place it just…

“Ba'al,” Sha're spat.

Oh. *That* one. Catra grimaced.

*****

The Clones Question Part 4

PT-9497 System, May 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Ba'al?" Jack O'Neill asked as he steered the stealth shuttle away from the drifting clone frigate. And away from the two frigates headed there to salvage it. The stealth generator was great, and the clones shouldn't be able to detect them even if they were almost touching their hull, but… the clones also shouldn't be following a snake.

"He's a Goa'uld who rose to prominence during the Second Goa'uld Dynasty on Earth, according to our records," Daniel replied. "He is associated with agriculture and was widely worshipped across the entire Mediterranean and beyond before the Goa'uld were overthrown. His worship continued, amongst other cultures by the Phoenicians, especially Carthage, and associated with human sacrifices, although the sources for that are mostly Roman, and so there's a certain bias to be considered when using them."

Jack checked the radar. No ships were pursuing them, so they should have evaded detection. Good. "I wasn't asking about the myth, but the snake. Isn't he one of the really bad System Lords?" And that took some doing for a snake.

"Although more subtle than Apophis, he's one of the most ruthless Goa'uld," Sha're said. "He kept his followers' loyalty through fear - like Sokar, with whom he was allied during the fight against Ra."

"Must have been the usual alliance amongst snakes," Jack commented, setting course for the outer system. Backstabbing from day one. Almost as bad as Pentagon politics.

"Apophis thought Sokar had dealt with him after Ra fell so he could make a move to succeed Ra as the ruler of the Goa'uld," Sha're said. "Neither Ba'al nor his forces had been seen in a while, and it seemed as if Sokar had absorbed many of his Jaffa."

“Apparently, that was not true,” Catra commented. “Looks like he was busy taking control of this Horde fleet.”

“Great. Just the thing we needed - a snake with superior technology,” Jack muttered. And right when it looked as if Earth had finally caught a break!

“Ba’al has a reputation for ruthlessness,” Teal’c spoke up. “It is said that he once sacrificed an entire world with millions of slaves to destroy an enemy fleet.”

“Sounds familiar,” Glimmer muttered.

“Ah… we always need to consider the source when judging people and, ah, Goa’uld. His rivals and enemies would have had a great interest in discrediting him to undermine his support and galvanise their own followers to fight him,” Daniel said.

“Apophis’s opinion matches the Tok’ra’s,” Sha’re said.

“Who are also his enemies,” Daniel retorted.

“You will be hard-pressed to find someone who doesn’t consider him an enemy, much less a friend of his,” Sha’re shot back.

“I admit that the evidence seems solid, multiple sources, but he has been hiding in obscurity for some time, hasn’t he?” Daniel said.

“As I said, he has a reputation for being subtle. And System Lords rarely change much if at all.”

“Indeed.”

Jack couldn’t help wondering if that was also how Daniel and Sha’re argued over small stuff in their marriage. And if Carter would do the same… Not that that was any of his business.

He cleared his throat. “So… he’s the type who would take over a Horde fleet and then use it covertly instead of demanding

everyone bow to him?" he asked as he altered their course - a patrol of Horde fighters was coming a bit too close for his taste.

"Yes."

"Indeed."

"The information we have would indicate that, but we need to check with the Tok'ra, I believe."

Great. "So, the fact that he hasn't done it doesn't mean he can't do it? He could have more than this fleet at his disposal?"

"We don't know how large this fleet is," Adora pointed out. "The ships we saw could have been the majority of his Horde forces."

"I don't think a Goa'uld would leave an underling with the majority of his forces," Catra said. "That leads to coups. He would try to keep the majority directly under his command and split the rest up between various officers. So, if this was, say, a third of his available forces, we're talking about half a fleet at the very least. And that's only his Horde ships. He'll have Goa'uld ships as well - and he'll likely upgrade them."

"That must be why he looted the shipyard we found," Adora agreed.

"We'll be fighting Super-Ha'taks," Jack muttered. "Isn't that great?"

"Oh, yes! I'm so curious to find out they adapted Horde technology to Goa'uld designs!" Entrapta cheered. "There are so many possible ways to upgrade them!"

Jack glanced over his shoulder, but everyone was frowning at him as if he had done something wrong. Even Carter.

It wasn't his fault that Entrapta was… a bit too focused on science instead of strategy or politics. Not that that was always a bad thing, mind you!

He sighed. “Well, the guys back in the Command Council won’t be happy about that.”

“I’m not happy about this either,” Glimmer said. “We need to focus on this Ba’al as soon as possible and take him out before he gets even more powerful.”

Jack nodded in agreement as he continued to fly them towards the meeting spot where the task force would pick them up.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, May 2nd, 2000

“...and then we took the flagship’s Stargate to return to Earth,” Adora finished with a nod at the assembled members of the Command Council.

“And the prisoner is still being interrogated?” Admiral Brown-Emerson asked.

“Yes. We’ve been able to confirm that he worships the Goa’uld Ba’al,” she replied. Not that had been hard - the clone had been praying to Ba’al as soon as he had woken up. “We have not been able to gather more intel, though - he is quite stubborn. But our analysts agree that it is very likely that the entire fleet is under the control of Ba’al.” If the clone had been an exception, if he had been a spy, he probably wouldn’t have carried Ba’al’s symbol at all - the Commander had had the two clones who had seen her demonstration killed just for their reaction; he’d do the same or worse to someone worshipping a Goa’uld, Adora was sure.

“I’m sure our specialists will be able to get him to talk,” General Naird said.

Adora slightly narrowed her eyes at him. Was he hinting at torture? The Alliance didn’t do that!

He blinked when he noticed her glare. “I mean, according to our files, clones have several psychological weaknesses that can be

exploited by skilled interrogators," he quickly added.

Ah. She nodded.

"Psychological weaknesses Ba'al must have exploited," General Steiner, a new addition to the Command Council from the Bundeswehr, said. "They were raised to obey Horde Prime without hesitation or question - he was literally the centre of their entire existence. It stands to reason that losing him would have left them terribly vulnerable to a skilled manipulator." He didn't have the German accent his retired predecessor had, Adora noted.

"And the snakes have been manipulating their faithful for thousands of years." Jack snorted. "They're very good at that."

Admiral Biggs, the replacement for the finally reassigned Admiral Kearsy, shook his head. "A weakness inherent to people who were raised without faith. That leaves a hole in their souls that the false gods can easily fill to control them."

Adora frowned again. That wasn't entirely correct, as she understood it. The Jaffa and slaves of the Goa'uld were raised from birth to worship the Goa'uld, at least the System Lords, as gods. And the clones might not have called Horde Prime their god, but they had effectively worshipped him as one.

But he was correct that losing Horde Prime had left many clones adrift, literally in the case of at least one force they had encountered, without direction or purpose. Many had become isolationist, refusing to accept that Horde Prime was dead, and were refusing any contact, driving away everyone, while waiting for Horde Prime to return. Others had become depressed. In some extreme cases, clones had just stopped doing anything, even eating, until they had died. Compared to that reaction, latching on to She-Ra instead to guide them was much better.

Anyway, this wasn't the time to discuss what was essentially semantics, she reminded herself.

“Actually, that’s wrong.” Of course, Daniel just had to disagree about that. “You can’t really claim that they lack faith. The Goa’uld’s power is based on faith.”

“It’s based on trickery and deceit - they are posing as gods, manipulating their followers. But they are false gods,” Biggs replied. He was clenching his teeth, Adora saw.

Teal’c nodded. “Indeed.”

“I think no one here disputes that they are false gods,” Daniel said. “But that doesn’t mean their followers lack faith. We have to take that into account when making plans about how to deal with this fleet. Recent converts tend to be fanatical, so we cannot count on them abandoning their new lord easily or quickly.”

“And we need to deal with them as soon as possible,” Jack added. “The longer Ba’al is allowed to build up his forces even more and upgrade his other ships and armies with Horde technology, the harder it will be to defeat him.”

“We have three Horde fleets to his one. If we keep one in reserve, we’ll still outnumber them two to one. Those are good odds,” Naird said.

“Moving First Fleet into his territory is a challenge already; moving another fleet as well?” Catra shook her head. “Even with the fleet trains reducing our need for bases and supply lines, the sheer distance we have to cover makes this a challenge. It would be much better if we could get them to desert him.”

Adora nodded. That would also save a lot of lives, which was an important point.

“Or at least start a civil war in the other fleet,” Catra went on.

That would cost a lot of lives.

Steiner looked up from his tablet. “That’s an excellent suggestion. We already know that a demonstration by She-Ra was enough to

sow doubts among the clones who witnessed it. Another such incident might cause a split in the fleet. At the very least, it should undermine Ba'al's claim to their loyalty."

Adora pressed her teeth together. "We can't rely on people converting because of me," she protested. That was… wrong.

Biggs nodded in apparent agreement.

"It's a possible strategy," Steiner defended the plan. "And it's much more likely to succeed than sending missionaries, isn't it? I doubt the clones would receive them well."

"They've also shot at us," Jack pointed out.

"Though if they're at least a bit like our clones, at least Third Fleet, they might try to convert more clones. That could offer opportunities for covert operations," Glimmer suggested.

"A decapitation strike against Ba'al?" Jack grinned.

"The last such operation was a failure," Naird said with a frown.

"We've learned from that," Jack retorted. "And taking out Ba'al would solve a lot of problems."

"We don't even know where he is and what resources he has - or what kind of bait we could use to lure him into a trap," Naird protested.

"Well, best we start working on that, then?" Catra grinned.

"And how do you suggest we do that?" Biggs asked with a slight snort.

"With our friends the Tok'ra." Catra flashed her fangs.

*****

Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, May 3rd, 2000

Samantha Carter knew the Tok'ra were sworn enemies of the System Lords. They had been fighting them for thousands of years, never relenting despite facing what seemed to be a hopeless battle. They went as far as to consider themselves another species despite being biologically identical.

And they had a unique culture. According to all accounts, they formed a true symbiosis with their hosts. Daniel even was of the opinion that a Tok'ra was the combination of a symbiont and host, not the symbiont themselves, though that view was contested among both the biologists and anthropologists specialised in aliens.

Sam still couldn't help but remember how she had been possessed by Jolinar when she greeted the Tok'ra delegation. Especially since amongst the three members was Martouf - Lantash/Martouf, she corrected herself - Jolinar's old lover. Or lovers. He said he had accepted that Sam was not Jolinar, even if she had seen some of their memories, and that she didn't share any of the feelings of the symbiont, but the way his polite smile changed just a tiny bit when he saw her still filled Sam with a brief mixture of revulsion and absolutely groundless guilt. She wasn't responsible for Jolinar's death.

"Anise. Freya. Jakar. Mats. Lantash. Martouf," she greeted them.

"Sam!" Anise - her voice gave her away - smiled warmly at her, though Sam didn't miss how her eyes wandered around the gate room.

"General O'Neill couldn't make it," she told her, hiding the small, petty satisfaction she felt at telling Anise that the object of her fascination wasn't here. "His duties at Alliance Special Forces Command keep him busy." Really, the woman should just accept that he wasn't interested in whatever she was offering.

"Duty comes first, of course." Anise nodded.

"Always," Jakar agreed.

“But he will join us at Headquarters, right?” Freya asked as Sam led them through the scanners.

“As the most experienced officer in the sort of missions we obviously are going to discuss, his absence from the meeting would be a surprise,” Jakar commented.

Sam hid her annoyance at the presumption as she nodded. “Yes, he'll be at Headquarters. As will Entrapta,” she added with a glance at Anise.

“Oh, good!” The Tok'ra nodded with what seemed genuine happiness. “I'm looking forward to discussing a few things with you after the meeting.”

“Oh?” Sam tilted her head as they left the gate room. That sounded promising. Anise was a great scientist with thousands of years of experience, and her designs were almost always unique and interesting.

“Yes. I've been working on a way to physically enhance humans, and I've hit a bit of a snag.”

That definitely sounded intriguing. But also worrying.

But first things first. Dealing with Ba'al's clone fleet took priority.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, May 3rd, 2000

The more the briefing continued, the more concerned the Tok'ra looked, Catra noticed. It was, of course, understandable - the situation was bad. Not the worst case they could have imagined; that would have been Horde Prime somehow having returned or invading from a different universe, or a Goa'uld taking over Adora, but it was a serious crisis.

Anise shook her head after the briefing on the contact with Ba'al's fleet had concluded. “A Goa'uld with that kind of power - the

resources he has access to, the technology at his disposal. He must be stopped at all costs!”

“He and all his followers have to be dealt with,” Jakar added. “Before they can adapt and spread Horde technology to other Goa'uld - or leverage this to take over the entire Goa'uld Empire.”

“Such an attempt would plunge the Goa’uld Empire into civil war though, wouldn't it?” Admiral Biggs said. “That would weaken them.”

Catra rolled her eyes. “Ba'al knows about us. If we try to exploit such an opportunity, he will use us as a threat to unite the Empire under him.” Nothing united people faster than a common enemy they couldn't defeat alone.

“We cannot wait and hope our enemies defeat themselves,” Adora added. “We must strike as soon as possible. And for that, we need to find Ba'al.”

“Or find the right bait to lure him into the open where we can strike at him,” Jack said.

Biggs scoffed. “That plan failed against Apophis and Sokar, and you want to try it again?

“Third time’s the charm.” Jack’s smile was very toothy, Catra noted - and she was sure it wasn't just because he didn't like the US Navy on principle.

Biggs scoffed again, “Superstition won't help us. Quite the contrary.”

“Actually, as the latest research studies show, this saying might be true as far as magic is concerned - at least in certain emerging magical traditions on Earth,” Daniel commented. When both Jack and Biggs glared at him, he winced and smiled weakly. “But this is probably not the time to discuss this.”

“Yes.” Glimmer nodded emphatically. “We need to focus on how to take out Ba'al.”

“A multi-pronged strategy seems most appropriate,” Admiral Brown-Emerson suggested. “A decapitation strike aimed at Ba'al, efforts to convert his followers and undermine his rule, but also a fleet operation as a last resort, to break his power before he can consolidate and expand it.”

“That would require the majority of the Alliance military,” Naird protested.

“It's not as if we're currently fighting major campaigns,” Jack told him.

“If Apophis launches another attack, we would be hard-pressed to counter him. Especially if he realises that we fooled him into thinking the Horde fleet is an enemy of Earth,” Naird retorted.

“If he realises the extent of our military capabilities, he'll know that he needs allies, and he'll attempt to unify the Goa'uld against us - and under his rule,” Sha're said. “That won't happen without us knowing about it,” she added with a glance at the Tok'ra.

Anise nodded. “Indeed. We do not have any assets at Ba’al's cort - yet - but a diplomatic move like that from Apophis would be noticed by our operatives. And I have stress again: A Goa'uld with Horde technology - or Ancients technology - is a lethal threat to us all. We have to focus on this menace above all.”

Catra nodded and leaned forward. “So, what can you do to help with that?”

Anise hesitated a moment, glancing at the others, and Catra narrowed her eyes. That wasn't a good sign.

*****

As he sat down on the edge of his desk in his office in Alliance Headquarters, Jack O'Neill felt a bit of nostalgia. The room was

bigger than his old office in Cheyenne Mountain, even bigger than Hammond's had been, but with over a dozen people inside, it felt as crowded as his old office had with just SG-1 inside. And, of course, back then, whatever they came up with still had to be approved by their superiors.

“So… What are we going to do?” he asked as soon as Teal'c had closed the door.

Anise, who had been unabashedly looking around in his office, no doubt looking for any insight about him that would help her get her hooks into him, or at least a sample of his genes or something, turned toward him. “I was of the impression that we just finished discussing this in the Command Council and had the matter delegated to various planning groups.”

“Yep, we did.” Jack grinned. “Which is why we now can start actually planning what we’ll do.”

Adora nodded. “We're not an official planning group, but nothing prevents us from making plans.”

“No one can stop us, anyway,” Catra added, stretching as she was perched on the edge of the meeting table.

Daniel, who had made a beeline for Jack's imported coffee-maker straight from the door, picked his cup up, took a sniff of the hot air wafting up, and nodded with a smile before turning to face the rest of the room. “I thought that the rest of the Command Council was pretty unhappy with us after the last two missions.”

He was right, but Jack still snorted with a careless shrug. “They're looking for someone to take the blame for the current crisis.”

Daniel frowned. “To be fair, our missions did have, ah, mixed results.”

Catra scoffed. “We were working on the intel we had, which turned out to be missing some crucial facts.”

“Such as Sokar's plans, and Ba'al's everything,” Jack agreed.

“Both System Lords have been hard to gather information on,” Jakar said. “Mostly because they spent so long in obscurity and eschewed regular contact with the rest of the Goa'uld.”

“It's annoying when the bad guys show good tradecraft,” Jack commented with a toothy grin.

Jakar matched it and nodded. “Indeed, it is.”

“But enough of that. We do have a crisis to solve,” Jack said. “How do we solve it?”

Adora took a step forward. “We've agreed to use a multi-pronged strategy. We'll reach out to the clones working for Ba'al to… persuade them to reconsider their allegiance.”

“To convert them,” Catra commented with a grin.

Adora frowned at her for a moment, then went on: “We'll mass our available ships for a campaign against Ba'al’s fleet, to overwhelm them before they can build up their strength even more, and we'll launch a decapitation strike mission directly against Ba'al as soon as we can.”

“Which means, as soon as we find him,” Catra piped up again with a pointed glance at Anise and the other Tok'ra.

Anise frowned a little at that. “As I said in the meeting, we'll send operatives out to infiltrate Ba'al's forces and instruct our spies currently working against Sokar to investigate their supposed ties.”

Catra waved her hand rather dismissively. “Yeah, yeah, that's standard procedure. But that won't get us the results we need in time to be useful - you've just started on Sokar, haven’t you?”

Anise pouted, but Jakar nodded. “Given the dangers and risks involved, we have to move cautiously when inserting spies, often

relying on chance and random opportunities, and that takes time."

Not for the first time, Jack thought that their snake allies had grown a bit too used to taking the very, very long view in their fight against the Goa'uld.

"Yeah, but that means we can't hope for a lucky break - we need to be proactive," Catra said. She slid off the table. "We need to launch aggressive recon missions."

Jack nodded. "Exactly."

"We're expanding the spy bot network into the suspected area under Ba'al's control," Carter said. "Though to accelerate this, we will have to rely on spaceships carrying more bots deeper into the target area. That will increase the risk of being detected and the network being exposed."

"That's a risk we have to take," Jack said. He doubted the spy bot network would last forever, anyway. "We need to find Ba'al's bases as soon as possible so we can infiltrate them and prepare strikes."

"That's good for their Jaffa and the Goa'uld ships, but the clone fleet won't need bases," Bow remarked. "And they can move around."

Which made them hard to find, Jack knew. Saturating the area with spy bots wasn't really practical, given how much time it would take.

"But if they rely on the fleet train to provide their other forces with advanced weapons, they will have to stay in close contact with it," Carter said. "We can use that to track them."

"And if Ba'al is the typical snake, he'll keep a close eye on all his forces, so we should be able to find him as well," Catra added.

"Yep," Jack said.

“I see.” Martouk nodded. “But in order to gather this mission without deep cover operatives will be very dangerous.”

“Indeed.” Teal'c nodded with a hint of a smile.

“Yep,” Jack agreed. “We'll have to sneak up on and into enemy bases and look around for any piece of intel we can get without being detected.”

“Oh, that sounds familiar.” Daniel sighed, but he was smiling a little as well.

As were the others in the room, except for the Anise and Martouf.

Jack grinned - he was feeling nostalgic again.

*****

Orbit Above Etheria, May 6th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Your Divine Highness! Welcome to the Herald of Salvation! The newest ship in your fleet!”

“Hello, Priest.” Adora smiled politely as she stepped down the ramp of the shuttle. “Did you choose the name?”

“It was chosen in light of her first mission, Your Divine Highness,” Priest replied as he straightened from his bow. “I found a more martial designation, such as chosen for our older ships, would not fit as well given that her mission is to save as many of our enemies as possible by showing them the light of Your Wisdom and Mercy.”

“And the fire of her improved beam cannons if they reject you,” Catra commented from behind her. “Can't let the hard work of Entrapta and the others go to waste, can we?”

“As the last resort,” Priest acknowledged, nodding his head at her. “We fervently hope that reason will prevail, and that our lost brothers will see the light. But we are aware of the challenges this

mission presents us with, and we will do our duty in Your service, Your Divine Highness."

Adora had already heard all the 'Divine Highness' she could stomach, but she knew from experience that telling Priest to call her anything else would only encourage him to come up with an even more ostentatious title, as Daniel had described it. So she nodded and tried to ignore it by focusing on the task at hand. "Yes. A fitting name for the flagship of the future Fourth Fleet."

"Indeed, Your Divine Highness! She will be a shining example for the rest of the fleet, and for the galaxy at large, of Your Grace and Courage!"

"Once she and the rest of the task force are crewed and worked up," Catra said.

"I have chosen the best and brightest from Third Fleet for this task, Your Divine Highness!" Priest replied. "They are well aware of the responsibility they have in shaping the core of Fourth Fleet's cadre so that our new brothers will serve you as faithfully as the other fleets."

"We will serve you with our lives, Your Divine Highness!" Padre, the clone chosen to lead this force, and the future Fourth Fleet, if he worked out, said, bowing deeply.

"I know you will," Adora told him, smiling gently. "All of you," she added, looking at the rest of the clones lined up to greet her. "You have my trust and my confidence."

"You honour us, Your Divine Highness!" Priest beamed at her, as did everyone else in the hangar except for Catra, who smirked.

Adora couldn't help feeling a little guilty and embarrassed at the display. She didn't deserve their worship. But they did deserve her trust. The Command Council had questioned this mission, voicing concerns that the ships of the recently founded Fourth Fleet should work up their crews, new clones mixed with veterans, safely inside Alliance space, in a training command, but Priest had

argued that the people forming the core of the crews for Fourth Fleet's first flotilla were all taken from Third Fleet's best and so they would be ready for deployment. Catra had agreed that getting actual field and combat experience as soon as possible would be better in the long run for the fleet's morale and esprit de corps. The sooner they were accepted as equal to the other Fleets, the better.

Adora had agreed. First Fleet and Second Fleet would provide most of the ships for this mission, anyway, so Fourth Fleet's small contribution wouldn't see action too soon - they still had yet to find the enemy's bases and deployments. So, the new fleet's new crews would get to train hard for the time being.

Still, she couldn't help worrying a little. Not only about the new clones serving on the new ships, fresh faces with new gear always meant problems in the field, she had seen that in both the horde and the Princess Alliance, but about the mission itself. Reaching out to the clones in Ba'al's service wouldn't be easy. Turning Horde soldiers had been hard enough in the Horde War on Etheria, and in space, the opportunities to make contact with potential deserters were far less.

And the danger for everyone involved was even higher, she reminded herself, remembering the two clones shot by their own bots after Adora's demonstration had shaken them.

No, Priest might be as confident as ever, but converting the clones following Ba'al wouldn't be easy at all.

But they would still try it, and give it their best shot. The clones manipulated by Ba'al deserved the chance to gain their freedom. And the Alliance would do their best to make it happen. Adora would ensure that.

*****

Orbit Above Etheria, May 8th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Inside the office they had appropriated on a yardship of First Fleet that had stayed in the system to keep building ships for Fourth Fleet, Samantha Carter was looking through Entrapta's latest proposal for a “science ship”. It was a far more practical design than her first one. Instead of a copy - at least in appearance - of a Miranda-class ship from Star Trek, it was a modified Horde frigate with the main beam cannon battery replaced by a greatly expanded version of the Spacelab Entrapta had built with Sam. Quite workable, in Sam's opinion - it shouldn't take long to alter the base schematics used by the Fleet Trains’ yardships; they had done that for a few improvements so far, the latest the beam cannons and shield projectors.

But the Spacelab part - it wasn't a module since it would be a permanent addition - would require more work. It would be quicker to custom-build it in a workshop instead of creating a prototype followed by the schematics for a yard… No. Once the war against the Goa'uld was over, there would be a need for such ships, so it was better to design them properly so they could be mass-produced easily and cheaply.

Which reminded her that she needed to go over the latest Fleet Transport schematics they had received; the British were planning to add some changes to the next block after the first block had started actual field deployment. The changes looked good, but Sam wasn’t quite sure if the relatively small increase in capability would be worth the added logistical and maintenance demands two versions of the same ship would cause. She would have to calculate that.

“So, what do you think?” Entrapta asked.

Sam felt a little guilty for having had her mind wander. That they both had a lot of tasks to do was no excuse in her opinion. She focused on the design again. “You've removed two-thirds of the beam cannons but left the power generators in place. That will allow more options during an emergency.” Such as the ability to shunt power to the engine or shields. Or to overload the beam cannons. With the main battery gone, the ship couldn't focus her

firepower; the remaining cannons were more a deterrent to attacks by swarms of fighters - a more potent point defence battery, actually. But overloaded, even those could, for a very short time, provide the ship with significant firepower at the cost of burning out the main focus crystals of the cannons involved.

Entrapta nodded. “Yes! And it will provide ample power to the lab for experiments!”

Right. Sam flushed a little - this was a science vessel, after all, not a military design. “And the shields will be able to withstand extreme conditions for longer.” That was a capability the latest Horde frigates had as well, but as with the enhanced beam cannons, trying to upgrade all existing ships would take too much time and yard capacity. They would have to stick to those ships undergoing regular maintenance or battle repairs, and the odd refit slipped in.

“Yes! Not enough to fly into a star’s corona - not yet - but we could dive quite a way into the atmosphere of a gas giant!” Entrapta beamed. “And if we overload the engines, we can get closer to a black hole!”

“I think disposable drones would be better for that,” Sam told her, smiling a little wryly. “Replacing drones is cheaper than overhauling the engines.” Or replacing them - or the ship, should the engines fail before the ship was in the clear.

“Right!” Entrapta's head bopped up and down as her hair tendrils flew over two keyboards at the same time. “Anyway, we can start building the prototype as soon as the fabber in section two finishes with the latest batch of cannons. I've checked it with Hordak; we've got five hours!”

That would be enough for a lot of the parts - the ones not requiring more advanced manufacturing, such as sensors. Though those they could get from the spy bot factories in the system; most of them had been retooled for ship sensors anyway since the spy bot network had spread so far, it was often more efficient for

expanding the networks to build automated factories further away than shipping bots from Etheria or Earth; those were mainly used for scouting and communication by task forces sent into areas not yet covered by the network. Such as Ba'al's suspected territory.

"Then let's get started," Sam said. "I didn't find anything I'd change." Though they would find a lot of things that would need changes once they actually used the prototype. No matter how good the design software and simulations were, some things you only noticed in actual use. A lesson the Navy sometimes seemed to forget.

"Yes! Now let's…"

Entrapta was interrupted by a beeping noise - a priority alert. Had something gone wrong? A new attack? Sam quickly changed the feed on her screen, and Entrapta swung over, carried by her hair, to look over her shoulder.

It was from the spy bot network. The bots had found a base in suspected Ba'al territory.

"That was fast," Entrapta commented, cocking her head to the side. "Faster than we expected. We're lucky!"

Sam wasn't sure about that. It could also mean that Ba'al had more bases than expected - or at least, more bases closer to Alliance territory than they had expected. Either wasn't good news.

*****

Orbit Above PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill couldn't help clenching his teeth when the stealth shuttle approached the planet. A dozen frigates were covering it, arrayed in three groups covering both poles and one in a geostationary orbit above the planet's main settlement - and his and his group's target.

If these were Alliance Horde frigates, they would have been detected already - this close, the stealth generator wouldn't be able to hide from upgraded sensors. But Ba'al's Horde lacked magitech. At least as far as we know, he thought, tensing up a little more.

Neither the frigates nor the patrols of Horde fighters flitting around between the three forces reacted to their presence, though. Hidden by their stealth generator, they were invisible. Unless one of the fighter patrols, which were coming a bit too close for comfort, literally flew into them, Jack could probably fly circles around them for shit and giggles.

“Passive sensor sweep concluded!” Entrapta announced cheerfully from the back of the shuttle. “Oh… You were right! Those are shipyards down there, but no ships are being built right now.”

They had known that from the spy bots that had discovered the system. Though they hadn't approached that closely; unlike their smaller infiltration versions, the space-capable bots weren’t built for that. And Jack wouldn't have trusted a bot to do this, either. Too much could go wrong on close recon missions. And too many opportunities could be wasted for lack of initiative - hacking computers, sabotaging enemy plans, taking out critical targets, freeing or taking prisoners… No, this mission needed people on the ground. The best people available.

“No ships? Are the yards finished?” Glimmer asked.

“The buildings are,” Carter replied. “Though passive scans are limited - we can't tell if the machinery and fabrication lines are set up and if the storage houses are full of the materials necessary for production.”

“If they aren't building anything they aren't ready,” Catra stated. “We wouldn't let them sit idle, and neither would Ba'al.”

Jack agreed and would have said so if they weren't about to enter the atmosphere and he had to focus on piloting the craft. This

was the most dangerous part of the mission. No matter how well you could fool enemy sensors, a ship entering a planet's atmosphere turned the air around it into superheated plasma, and that tended to be quite noticeable from afar.

The stealth generators tried to compensate for that, and did to some extent thanks to Carter and Entrapta's work, but even with magitech, you just couldn't hide all the light and heat.

So, Jack had to carefully follow a course that avoided the bulk of the enemy fleet and stayed as far as possible from patrolling fighters, and even so, there was still a risk that someone caught a glimpse of them and didn't mistake it for a meteor burning up in the atmosphere.

He kept a careful eye on the enemy while he took the shuttle down, but the Horde fighters stuck to their routes like glue - one of the disadvantages of using bots as crew, Jack guessed. Their own faced the same issues, but they simply didn't have enough trained pilots to crew all their fighters.

A few tense minutes later, they were low and slow enough so they were safe from passive detection, and Jack changed course toward their target. Still no pursuit or any sign that they had been detected.

He grinned. If he wanted to, he could land the shuttle right next to the base on the planet. Not that he would do it, of course. He was no fool. The risk of being spotted by ground patrols was too high. They wouldn't see them, and as long as the shuttle kept hovering, the ground wouldn't be flattened either, but if a patrol found tracks ending in nowhere, or dead birds that had flown into the invisible shuttle, or any other possible clue, it wouldn't take a genius to put two and two together and realise that the Alliance had much better stealth capabilities than the Goa'uld or Horde had. And that would be a major hindrance to future missions in addition to threatening one of their biggest advantages, the spy bot network.

Halfway across the planet's biggest ocean - he was flying low enough to avoid most sensors, just high enough not to leave a wake in the water - he keyed the intercom. “Hello, everyone! We're about to land at our destination. The weather is cloudy with a chance of Jaffa and bot patrols, both on foot and in the air, so dress accordingly, and thank you for flying with O'Neill Air!”

A round of chuckles from everyone and a sigh from Carter answered his joke, and he grinned. Nothing like a joke to lighten the mood before things got serious.

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The Clones Question Part 5

Outside Ba'al's Base, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"They need better perimeter checks."

Adora agreed with Catra's comment as she crawled up a bit more up the ridge to get a better view of the closer walls surrounding the base in front of them. She'd have to use binoculars, but it was still better than relying on aerial pictures or adapted sensor data. There was just something to taking a look in person at the enemy. Especially as a commander.

"I've seen worse from the Horde," Glimmer said behind her.

"Must have been a rear-echelon unit, not frontline troops." Catra joined Adora next to her.

"We sneaked past frontline Horde guards as well." And there was Bow.

"You did. But it took you more of an effort," Catra said. "We slipped through their patrols without trying."

"If the enemy is screwing up, you won't see me complaining," Jack commented.

"It's a matter of professional pride," Catra said. "This is basic stuff."

"Indeed."

Adora focused on the base below. It was huge - it included a spaceport large enough to handle four Ha'taks at once and shipyards with three 'slips' for capital ships, open to the sky - she could see the beginnings of what looked like Ha'taks there. And next to those were factories for the various weapons and other parts that would go into the ships. At least according to their

sensor scans. And there were more factories adjacent to the shipyard complex. And a high wall surrounded it. Constructing it would have taken a long time.

"That's not a forward base or even a supply hub," Catra commented. "That's an industrial centre. And we're barely past the border here."

"Very vulnerable," Glimmer said.

"That makes the guards' failure even worse. They should be better this close to the front," Catra insisted.

"They might not have considered this a potential front when they built it," Bow said. "It's close to Alliance space around Etheria, but we're further away from the known Goa'uld territories Ba'al is attacking."

"They should have reinforced it with better troops after they tried to kill us," Catra said. "Ba'al isn't a fool. And this is an important base. Can't he spare some elite troops?"

"Maybe he has even more such hubs in his core territory?" Daniel suggested.

Adora clenched her teeth. That would be even worse. But… "If he had such a broad industrial base, wouldn't he have a lot of guards as well?"

"The false god might rely on the ships in orbit to guard this facility," Teal'c suggested. "And he might be saving his veteran warriors for more important tasks than guarding his bases."

Catra scoffed. "Let's hope he's that stupid. Guarding your supply lines is crucial against a mobile enemy."

"If he's underestimating us, I'm not complaining," Jack said.

"Really? I think I remember…"

“Focus, Daniel! We’re on a mission in Indian country, not on a trip down memory lane.”

“But…”

“Speaking of troops…” Adora zoomed in on the barracks visible on the base. “If those are standard troop barracks, then there should be more soldiers around than we see.”

“They might be housing workers there as well,” Bow said.

“No. The false gods do not allow their slaves to stay in the quarters for their warriors,” Teal’c said. “The slave quarters are distinctively poorer. And the warriors would not relax next to the slaves’ quarters like those we see below.”

Several Jaffa were hanging out, or so it seemed, in front of the buildings. At least they were not standing at attention but sitting, and a few were sparring, but it didn’t look like the kind of organised training Adora would have expected. So, Teal’c was probably correct - it was too far for Melog to check with their senses. Then that meant that the workers lived… There, in the plain buildings next to the shipyard complex, she noted.

“Are those quarters full? Can you scan for capacity and check if the number of people matches it?” Adora asked.

“Yes!” Entrapta, who had stayed below the ridge, replied. “Let me just program the scanner for this… Done!”

A few seconds passed. Adora watched a Death Glider take off from a pad near the factory complex. Was that a test flight? Or a courier or shuttle mission? It didn’t look like a patrol.

“OK… looks like the people present easily fit into the quarters we have scanned. They could actually fit twice the number in there!” Entrapta reported.

“So, they’re planning to expand. Or that’s for the crews for the ships they’re building here,” Jack commented. “Can you tell if the

stuff down there is the stuff they looted from the planet they attacked?"

"One moment, sir - running a scan detailed enough to compare the details necessary for such a distinction will take some time," Sam replied.

Adora studied the defences visible from their spot. Towers with crew-served weapons, but no heavier weapons. Without the ships above them, the base would be helpless against orbital strikes.

"All that production capacity and no integrated defences worth a damn?" Catra echoed her thoughts. "Is this a trap, or can't he spare the resources?"

"Well," Jack said next to them, "that's what we're here to find out. Among other things. Let's see how we can sneak inside!"

*****

"So? Any convenient openings? Like, an unguarded sewer?"

"No, sir." Sitting in front of her laptop below the ridge hiding them from view, Samantha Carter shook her head at the General's question. "The wall surrounding the base has been constructed quite competently. There are no openings for wastewater - according to our scanners, it's filtered on-site in underground treatment plants." She double-checked her scans, just in case she had missed something. She hadn't.

"Yes. That's quite environmentally friendly," Entrapta added. "The other Goa'uld bases we saw were much less careful about their ecological footprint."

"Figures that the one time the snakes care about the environment, it's to our detriment," the General muttered.

"I am quite certain that Ba'al does not care about the environment," Teal'c spoke up. "If he ordered this, then he did it because of security concerns."

“Yes,” Sha’re agreed.

“Or he figured that having his freshwater sources polluted would harm the base’s productivity long-term,” Sam pointed out.

“That would mean this base isn’t meant to be a temporary installation,” Catra said.

“Unless that’s his standard procedure,” Daniel suggested. “He might be more focused on long-term planning than most Goa’uld - although given their lifespan, most of them should be taking long-term consequences into account.”

“They should, and some System Lords do, but Ba’al has not such a reputation,” Sha’re disagreed.

“His reputation might not conform to his actual actions,” Daniel replied. “We only have second-hand information to judge him.”

“Well, we’re here to get some first-hand information,” the General cut in. “So, let’s focus on how to get into the base instead of analysing data we don’t have, shall we?”

Sam nodded, feeling a bit stung by the reminder - she had not stopped analysing the data the scanner was providing, even though it hadn’t given any actionable results yet. “Half a dozen gates offer access, but they are heavily guarded,” she reported. A full squad of Jaffa outside the gates, backed by more inside, weapon instalments on the wall, and more sensors than the Goa’uld usually employed.

“Yeah, we saw that,” the General agreed.

“And it doesn’t look like the gates are used much except for patrols leaving and returning,” Catra added.

“In a pinch, we could ambush a patrol, take their armour and clothes and sneak in like that - some of us,” Bow said. “Though they would find out afterwards.”

“And we’d be limited to four people, and all of them would have to be able to pass as Jaffa,” the General said.

And unless they wanted to rely on Melog constantly keeping up illusions, all of them would have to be men. Teal’c, obviously, the General, Bow and Daniel were the only ones, though they might be able to dress up Adora, if changed into She-Ra, as a Jaffa guard with some work - she certainly had the height.

However, neither Sam nor Entrapta would be able to sneak in like that, and while Sam trusted Bow’s technical skills, she really wanted to personally hack the enemy systems.

“And we’ve done that on Saqqara,” Catra pointed out. “Ba’al might expect that trick.”

That was also a good argument - fooling the sensors installed at the gates wouldn’t be easy. Not impossible, but it would be a challenge, especially if they had to do it from afar.

“What are the alternatives?” Adora asked.

“Return the planet’s magic, and I teleport us inside?” Glimmer suggested.

“They might notice Adora changing the surface of the entire planet,” the General replied. “These kinds of side-effects tend to draw attention.”

“I could do something else with the magic,” Adora said.

“Something the ships in orbit won’t detect?” The General raised his eyebrows.

“Maybe?” Adora frowned. “If I channel the magic into the ground… I could make a tunnel into the base!”

That sounded… possible, but Sam didn’t like to trust the plan - and their lives - to Adora improvising a magic feat. That kind of gamble should be left for desperate situations, in her opinion.

But she couldn't see any alternative that was significantly better. The base was surrounded by cleared land that didn't offer any cover, so even if they hacked the sensors, they couldn't sneak up to the base. Melog's illusions couldn't turn all of them invisible out in the open like that, either. Although… "The raw materials!" She was already checking the sensor data - expanding it to cover more of the world.

"The raw materials?" the General asked.

"They need raw materials to build all those ships and other gear," Sam explained while she sorted through the data.

"They mine asteroids," Entrapta said. "That's standard Horde fleet train procedure."

"Yes. But there are some raw materials you can't get from asteroids. Like food." And a few others, of course, especially for chemicals.

"The Horde clones are used to eating food grown in tanks," Catra said. "The Horde never really cared about the quality of their rations."

"The grey ones were good, though," Adora objected.

"They were not as bad as the brown ones, but they weren't good."

Sam ignored the bickering and sifted through the older data.

"But the Jaffa aren't the Horde. At least the Jaffa warriors serving the System Lords we knew about generally don't live on a diet of vat-grown food," Daniel said.

"Indeed," Teal'c agreed. "While it is not impossible that loyal warriors would bear such conditions, most warriors I know would consider it beneath them to live on such fare."

"We haven't seen farms around the place, though," Sha're pointed out. "And they could ship in food from other worlds."

"But that would be requiring more spacelift," the General said. "And you never have enough transport capacity. So…"

"...they will be mining and producing what resources they can on the planet," Sam finished his thought. "I've identified two mines and one aquafarm on the sensor data we gathered on approach, sir."

"Good work, Carter!"

She tried not to smile too much at the praise.

"Alright, folks - we have a transport to hitch a ride on!"

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Outside Ba'al's Mine, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"For someone paranoid about security, this transport seems suspiciously easy to board," Catra commented as she looked at the vehicle below her.

"It's guarded by a squad of Jaffa and has integrated sensors," Adora commented from behind her. "And it's in the middle of the mine compound."

Catra snort. "As I said - suspiciously easy to board." Entrapta, Sam and Bow were already hacking the sensors, and the four Jaffa kept a close eye on their surroundings, but she didn't see them looking up very often.

"We're not going to sneak inside the compound, anyway," Jack added. "Let's get into position."

Catra nodded and crawled backwards until she couldn't be seen from below, then circled around the big rocks lining the ridge to

join the rest waiting at the ambush point. Well, the boarding point - it wasn't as if they were going to attack the transport.

"I'm feeling nostalgic," Bow said as he arrived as well. "We used to catch Horde transports like that all the time back in the war."

"Only until I beefed up security," Catra told him. "You didn't nab many of the convoys."

"There were enough solitary transports to pick off." Glimmer said.

Catra shrugged. "Can't really send a convoy to an outpost when they only need a single transport. But it's no big loss, either." The Horde planning had always anticipated some losses when calculating supplies. Hordak and hers, at least - Horde Prime had been a perfectionist. Then again, when your supply lines were part of your space fleets, you didn't have to make the same compromises both sides had been forced to on Etheria.

Glimmer snorted. "When we got a convoy, though, half your front collapsed."

Catra forced herself to shrug again. "That was back when the soldiers were deserting en masse anyway." She might have been able to stabilise the horde forces, but… She didn't like to remember that time of her life.

And she didn't need to glance over at Melog to know they had changed colours.

Adora cleared her throat. "Anyway, get ready to board the transport. They won't take much longer."

"We'll know when they're starting to move," Bow said, holding up his tablet. "We can see everything their sensors see, and they're still loading up."

Catra snorted. Adora hasn't been very subtle in her attempt to change the subject, but Bow still had missed it. Whatever. She crawled ahead a bit, up the ridge and past a sensor they had

hacked on the way in - Ba'al apparently hadn't the troops to spare to complement his sensor grid, which meant it was easy to bypass them with the right technology - and looked at the area below.

Hidden behind a scraggly bush, she could clearly see the dirt road the transports' wheels had dug into the ground in the last few months. The Horde might as well have paved the entire road; that would have been as obvious and would have allowed for higher speeds.

As things were, the transport would be going quite slow in the curve here - she could see dusty tracks and some traces of paint on the rock wall on the other side, showing that at least one transport had taken the turn with too much speed. So, it was the perfect spot to board it without anyone noticing.

They just had to drop down about five yards onto a moving vehicle to pull it off.

But that wasn't really a problem.

"They stopped loading the transport," Bow announced from below.

"Get up then!" Catra hissed.

The rest of the group started scrambling up the slope and spread out along the ridge.

"They've left the compound," Bow reported.

Catra's ears twitched - she could already hear the transport's engine. It wasn't Horde technology but more advanced than the usual Goa'uld setup. Then again, any kind of engine was more advanced than some of the transports used on planets ruled by the snakes.

"Get ready!" Jack sounded tense, but they had this in the bag.

And there came the transport, slowly taking the corner ahead of them.

“Sensors fooled, sir,” Sam reported.

“Go!”

Catra waited a moment - she could have jumped already, but the driver might have spotted her from that angle - then launched herself off the ridge and through the air, landing lightly on the back of the transport in a crouch. She resisted the instinct to dig her claws into the vehicle’s roof and quickly glued the lines she had carried with her to the top using Bow’s gadgets.

Glimmer, Sam and Jack were sliding down from the ridge on lines before Catra could give the signal. Teal’c brought up the rear - the transport had already passed his position when he jumped off and slid down as well. Entrapta, propelled by her hair, didn’t bother with the lines in the first place.

The hair tendrils cushioned her impact like a big spring, then unfolded - just in time to catch Adora, who was carrying Daniel and Sha’re with her when she jumped. Next to her, Melog landed as gracefully and softly as any cat would in their place.

Catra sliced through the lines with her claws as soon as Teal’c was clear, then watched the things disappear thanks to Melog’s illusions.

Good. Now, they just needed to get inside the transport and hide behind another illusion, and they would be set.

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On the Way to Ba’al’s Base, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Leaning back against the wall inside the transport, Jack O’Neill couldn’t help feeling that this was a bit too easy. Of course, sneaking onto a poorly-secured ore transport - and rare earth, not Naquadah or anything else that was worth its weight in gold or something - wasn’t exactly the same as sneaking into a System Lord’s palace, but Ba’al was supposed to be a crafty bugger, and

supply transports were an obvious weakness for the base he had otherwise locked up pretty well. With Horde technology, too, not just Goa'uld gear - although that could include Ancients tech as well, those snakes were worse than magpies, or submarine crews, when it came to getting gear.

On the other hand, Jack and his friends had magic, and the snakes didn't. And while Jack didn't like magic for several completely valid reasons, the least of them being that he wasn't a magical princess or witch and didn't want to be one, he liked having an edge on his enemies. And Melog's magic was very effective - anyone looking into the transport would just see ore containers and nothing else. Jack had checked it himself after they had sneaked inside. Coupled with Carter and Entrapta fooling the security systems, they should pass the inspection at the gates - the ones they had observed relied on scanners and the good old mark I eyeball.

Still, that was no reason to grow complacent. Overconfidence killed you. You underestimated your enemy at your own peril. And Ba'al, according to everything they knew, was a crafty little…

"We're approaching the base, sir," Carter's whisper interrupted his thoughts.

Jack sat up straighter, as did the others.

"Scanner-jammer's ready!" Entrapta announced.

"Checking with the shuttle… Bow's connection to the hacked security sensors is stable," Carter reported. "No unusual activity detected in the security system."

Good. Jack nodded. "Showtime, folks!" He gripped his carbine and ran a quick before-operations check out of reflex. The M4 was, as it should be, in perfect condition, loaded with the new armour-piercing-incendiary ammo the eggheads had come up with. It wasn't a magic bullet despite the hype and rumours, and it didn't use magitech but advanced technology to ensure that any Jaffa

hit would be sporting a burning hole front to back. Probably the wall behind them as well.

Jack had reserved the entire first production run for his command, of course.

Carter wasn't checking her own weapon - she was too busy typing on her computer to deal with whatever technological thingie Ba'al's Jaffa were trying to detect them - but he trusted her not to neglect her weapon as he trusted Teal'c to maintain his staff weapon.

"We've arrived," Carter reported, though Jack had already felt the transport slowing down - and becoming smoother; they weren't shaken as hard every time the wheels hit a hole or rock or whatever any more.

Then they came to a stop, the engine's droning noise ending, and Jack took a deep breath. If they were spotted, they would be exposed to fire from at least two weapon emplacements from the wall and a squad of Jaffa up close. Adora could take care of the heavy weapons, but in a crossfire, she wouldn't be able to block every shot. And Bow would take some time to get them with the shuttle.

He glanced at Carter, who signalled with her hand. So, the scans had started. No shouting or shooting outside. One of the Jaffa would check the undercarriage, another would climb on a tyre to check the roof. Fortunately, they hadn't left any traces up top.

Did the transport just rock a bit? Jack didn't think even a Jaffa in full armour would be able to affect the ore transport, but…

The loading doors in the back opened, and Jack held his breath as he raised his weapon to aim it at the Jaffa climbing inside. If the man physically checked the containers…

But the Jaffa pulled out a familiar scanner - standard Horde gear - and slowly turned around, attention focused on the thing's screen as he pointed it at the interior of the transport. Seconds passed,

then the Jaffa nodded and climbed out - jumped out - again, calling out as soon as he hit the ground.

A moment later, the loading doors closed, and Jack slowly released his breath. He glanced at Catra, whose ears were twitching, and she signed the all-clear.

Then the transport's engine started up again with a shirt whine, and then they were moving inside the base - headed straight to one of the warehouses, where the raw materials for the shipyards were stored. Being inside that huge structure would make it easier to slip out of the transport and hide somewhere.

About a minute later, the transport slowed down to a stop again - they must have arrived at the entrance. Catra winced a moment later, and Jack heard a faint screeching noise. Someone must have failed to lubricate the doors, he thought. That didn't matter, though - he doubted they would use the cargo doors when leaving.

Once more, the transport stopped. Now came the tricky part. They would have to slip out while the real containers were being unloaded. However, that shouldn't be too hard with the way the thing was set up. And Melog had assured them through Catra that they could keep them hidden for that.

The loading doors in the back didn't open, though.

And Catra whispered: "Something's hissing outside. And it smells awful."

Jack looked at Carter and caught her gasping. That was never a good sign.

"We're in the decontamination area," she said, eyes glued to her computer. "Where they wash the transports. But… they're not using cleaning solvents. It's poison!"

*****

Ba'al's Base, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Masks on!"

Poison? Adora froze for a moment as she put on her mask. That wouldn't stop nerve gas, though. She could heal poisonings. But… for how long? And if she released the magic of this world, they would be noticed. But…

"It's a trap!" Daniel gasped.

"I can't teleport without magic."

"I don't hear any alerts!" Catra snapped. "Might be standard procedure."

"Standard procedure or not, poison is poison!" Jack spat. "Can you identify and stop it?"

"Working on it, sir," Sam replied. Her fingers were flying over the keyboard of her laptop.

"Seal the compartment!" Catra blurted out.

"Working on it!" Entrapta's hair was whipping around, carrying several tools.

Adora heard a hissing noise and tensed, but it was coming from one of Entrapta's tools.

"I'm sealing the seams, but that won't stop a nerve agent," Entrapta said. "And we just got confirmation - it is a nerve agent! But it will slow it down. We don't have the gear we need to seal the compartment against chemical weapons. An unfortunate oversight."

"I've stopped the poison dispenser," Sam reported. "And I've blocked the sensors from reporting it. But we need to neutralise it before we can leave the transport."

“They have to decontaminate the transport before unloading the cargo,” Sha’re said. “We can just wait.”

“By then, the agent will have contaminated this compartment,” Sam said.

“Can you trigger the decontamination procedure? I can heal us until then,” Adora said.

Catra narrowed her eyes at the ceiling. “I think I can hear it entering.”

Oh, no! Adora drew her sword.

“I risk alerting the base guards if I do that. I’ll have to fake a glitch,” Sam replied. “And I think they open the cargo compartment for that.”

“Do it anyway!” Jack said.

Adora started healing people. If only she could deal with the gas like that… But this wasn’t the time to experiment with her power.

Catra cocked her head. “Hoses are working.”

Adora didn’t relax. Nerve agents lingered - they had learned that in cadet training.

“It’s already seeping through,” Glimmer pointed out - indeed, drops were running down the sides of the transport.”

“That won’t be enough to decontaminate the inside,” Sam said. “We’ll have to wait until they open the door and repeat it.”

Adora winced.

And Catra cursed. “Do you know how much it takes to clean your fur?”

Adora knew. As did Melog, who looked green again - and Adora didn’t think that was just reflecting Catra’s mood. They really

needed uniforms that protected against such agents. Masks wouldn't cut it. They could use the space suits, but as light as they were, they were still too heavy to be worn if there were better alternatives. She made a mental note to make it a priority - they had started a project for such uniforms after the encounter with the Eurondans, but as she dimly recalled, it was still held up in a committee where people argued over who got to make them for the Alliance.

The liquid started to run down the walls. At least, this was the decontamination agent, not the nerve agent. Adora still doubted that it was good for your skin.

"Quiet! I hear someone coming!" Catra hissed.

"Finally!" Jack muttered under his breath as Melog hid them again.

Then the doors were opened - by a worker, Adora noted, who wasn't wearing any protective gear - and as soon as the man had withdrawn, the hoses started up again - and two were spraying the stuff in the compartment. Adora closed her eyes and clenched her teeth when the liquid hit her.

It went on and on, and there was nothing she could do - she just had to endure this. Others had it worse, even. Catra was the worst off, Adora knew, with her fur and her big ears.

But after about a minute, the hoses were turned off again. Adora's skin itched and she had to struggle not to scratch herself - she would have to heal everyone again once they were out of this compartment.

But before they could leave, two Jaffa in armour climbed inside, and Adora tensed again. Had they been made? Was this a reaction to the 'glitch'?

They looked around for a few seconds, talking briefly in Goa'uld. Both snorted and left again.

“The first one said that if any escaped slave had been in here, they’d have died trying to open the doors, so there was no need to get wet climbing over the containers,” Daniel whispered.

Adora gasped. So, that was why they poisoned the transports!

Daniel coughed. “The second said…”

“...that they would find any dead ones anyway,” Jack finished for him. “No, I didn’t understand him - that was just a guess. Guards will be guards.”

Catra snorted, then cursed even more and rubbed her ears. “Let’s get out now before the workers arrive.”

“Yes.” Adora looked at Melog. “Can you hide us until we’re clear?”

They nodded, and everyone started moving to the loading doors. Adora peeked outside - the coast was clear. And they were hidden by magic, anyway.

“Sensors fooled,” Entrapta said.

“Let’s go!” Adora slid down to the ground - jumping would make noise - and started towards the centre of the warehouse. They could hide between the tons of raw materials stored there and plan their next move.

And she could heal them. She hoped they’d find a way to get clean as well.

*****

They’d made it out of the transport just before the workers arrived to unload it. As Samantha Carter had expected, the slaves weren’t wearing protective gear. In the rush to get away and into a hiding spot, she hadn’t been able to see if the men and women showed any symptoms of health problems from long-term exposure to the decontamination agent, but she wouldn’t be surprised at all if that was the case - agents used to neutralise

neurotoxins were often toxic themselves. Certainly, Sam's skin was already irritated by the agent. And if Ba'al followed the usual Goa'uld policy of not offering any health care to his slaves, then he would have to replace those workers quite often to keep the output here up.

"Here, let me…"

Warmth filled her, and the irritating - and concerning, Sam was all too aware of the damage such agents could do - itching feeling vanished as Adora healed her.

"We need to get this damn stuff off us," the General muttered after peeking around the corner of the container behind which they were hiding. "We can't do the mission if you have to keep healing us every few minutes."

"We could tough it out," Glimmer suggested.

"Says the woman who has been scratching herself for minutes before Adora healed you." Catra sounded very irritated herself. Then again, as she had told everyone, her fur was sticky, and her ears drove her crazy. Her tail was whipping back and forth, either from tension or in an attempt to shake out more of the decontamination fluid. Maybe both, Sam guessed.

"We'll need to find a shower," she said - after briefly checking if the agent would react badly with water. It shouldn't, or the slaves' condition would be far worse, but you always checked such things because the cost of finding out after you already screwed up was usually horrible.

"Well, if we ask nicely, maybe the garrison will let us use theirs…" If she hadn't known already how frustrated the General was, his sarcasm would have told her. He usually was a little more constructive in those situations.

"We could build a shower. We just need a source of water," Entrapta suggested.

Sam blinked. Building a shower? That would… It sounded absurd at first thought - and she didn't want to think about the comments it would cause during their debriefing or the rumours it might create - but it should be a suitable solution for their problem.

"I'm looking for a source of water," she said, starting a search with her scanner. "We'll need a location where we can drain the water as well." Although Goa'uld tended not to care much about such details, someone might notice a slightly toxic puddle of water left where no such thing should be.

"And which offers us some privacy. Don't want to start any rumours," the General said, nodding emphatically.

Sam agreed wholeheartedly.

"Rumours?" Entrapta cocked her head and frowned. "About showering?"

Sam clenched her teeth and pretended to be focused entirely on her scanner.

"Ah, right - you guys still aren't used to mixed units," Glimmer said.

"We're used to mixed units," the General retorted. "Just not to shared showers."

"Must be rough in the field," Catra commented - and Sam could *hear* her smirk.

"We manage," The General replied blandly.

"But that seems inefficient," Entrapta said. "You'd have to either have a schedule or separate facilities, and either will add friction to your organisation."

"Not as much friction as shared showers would, trust me," the General said, and Sam knew without looking at him that he was grinning in that slightly lopsided way.

“That seems like a problem we need to address, then,” Adora said.

She isn’t wrong, Sam thought. Sexism was alive and well in the armed forces. She had met her fair share of soldiers and officers she wouldn’t trust in such a situation. But they were in the middle of a mission, and this wasn’t the time to discuss Alliance policies. Her skin was already itching again! “I think I found a spot, sir,” she spoke up, pointing at the location on her screen. “It’s not too far from here, quite isolated, and the sound from the processor next door should mask any from the water. Or from building the shower.”

“Right, let’s go! I’m itching for a shower,” the General announced.

“Jack! That was bad even for you!”

“Less complaining, more moving.”

*****

Catra’s fur was still wet. So was her uniform. Sam and Entrapta should have built a dryer as well as a shower - or ‘improvised decontamination facility’, as Sam insisted on calling it, at least officially. It was a shower, though. Not that anyone would care, anyway - they hadn’t even taken off their uniforms to shower. They were wet, and it was uncomfortable.

She ran her hands down her bare arms, then gripped her tail and tried to squeeze more water out of her fur. Sneaking around would be harder if they left a trail of puddles. Then she shook her head, trying to clear her ears again.

“Hey!” Glimmer hissed. “Watch it. I don’t need another shower!”

Catra snorted. “It’s just a few drops.”

“Then you shouldn’t make a fuss over it!”

Catra glared at Glimmer. She was the one who had to deal with wet fur! Then she blinked and smirked. At least her wet uniform wouldn't rub against raw skin until it finally dried. If it ever did.

Glimmer narrowed her eyes in return. "What?"

"Nothing." Catra smiled sweetly.

"You just thought of something!"

"Yeah, that we need to dry off some more before we sneak around. Don't want to leave a trail of water for anyone to follow," Catra said.

"The squelching noise is also not going to help with that," Jack added. "We need to take that into account when making better uniforms."

"Already noted, sir," Sam chimed in.

"Should just switch to standard Horde uniforms," Catra said. "They're rated against environmental attacks."

"They're not rated for all chemical and biological weapons we know now, though," Entrapta chimed in. "We'd have to adjust the design. And we would have to either build new factories or re-repurpose the ones we repurposed to make other stuff after the war."

"We can't have the Alliance dressing up as Horde troops!" Glimmer gasped. "There would be an uproar back home!"

"Yeah. They didn't like my uniform either when I first joined them," Adora said.

"I was kidding," Catra flashed a grin that earned her another scowl from Glimmer. "But we do need better uniforms." She bent down and rubbed the fur on her feet.

“You’ve never worn a standard Horde uniform,” Glimmer pointed out.

Of course not! Catra snorted and flexed her claws. “Even the Horde realised that they had to make adjustments for me.”

“I remember!” Entrapta beamed. “I did warn you that such modifications would compromise the uniform’s integrity, didn’t I?”

Catra nodded. “You did.” But the Alliance hadn’t used chemical or biological weapons - well, not the poison kind - so it hadn’t mattered much.

“Are we really discussing fashion in the middle of a mission?” Jack complained.

“No. We’re talking shit while drying off until we can continue the mission without leaving wet footprints all over the site,” Catra shot back.

“We could still build a dryer. We just need a few more parts and we need to hack the systems so the excess heat and additional power drain won’t trigger the internal sensors,” Entrapta suggested.

Catra knew from experience what her friend considered ‘a few more parts’ and shook her head. “No time for that.”

“Yes. Besides, the people back home would never stop with the vacation jokes,” Jack agreed. “We just have to tough it out.”

“Just like trekking through a swamp in boot camp, right?” Daniel asked in a rather sarcastic tone.

Jack beamed at him. “Exactly like that, just without the mud sucking your boots off!”

Catra snorted at Daniel’s pouty expression - he shouldn’t try to outsnark Jack.

“Alright. Let’s go,” Adora spoke up. “I think we’re dry enough.”

Catra swallowed the first remark that came to mind and nodded. They could leave the warehouse through the side entrance they had scoped out from outside the base. From there they could quickly reach what Sha’re and Teal’c had agreed was the main administration building of the base. They just need to ensure that the ‘decontamination facility’ was dismantled before leaving their hideout here.

“Wait!” Sam’s voice made everyone stop and turn to her. “I’ve been going over the warehouse’s manifest. There’s a suspicious item we should check.”

“Suspicious how?” Jack asked.

“It’s listed as ‘special supplies’, but I can’t match it to anything factory or repair installation in the base.”

That did sound suspicious. “Special project?” Catra wondered.

“Let’s hope it’s not some ‘special weapon’,” Jack said.

“Let’s go check it out,” Adora said.

Catra took point as they left their hideout and led them through the maze of containers and stacked other materials to the site Sam had identified. It was a sealed container. Horde-style, far more advanced than the cargo containers in the rest of the facility.

Hacking the lock didn’t take long, though - Ba’al might have access to Horde tech, but the Alliance had been hacking their security for years at this point. After half a minute, the doors of the container opened with a slight hissing noise, and Catra moved ahead of everyone else to take a peak.

It was dark inside, but her eyes adjusted easily - and she gasped.

The container was filled with pods. Pods containing people - humans. *Identical humans*.

*****

The Clones Question Part 6

Ba'al's Base, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"So… We're either looking at the galaxy's only case of… fifty-plets or Ba'al has been playing around with cloning technology," Jack O'Neill said, staring at the double rows of pods containing people.

"I think the word you wanted to use is 'quinquagintuplets', Jack," Daniel said. "Not 'fifty-plets'."

Jack cocked his head to the side and rolled his eyes at his friend. Daniel was the geeky language guy, not Jack. "The meaning was clear."

"Yes, but…"

"And," Jack went on, "let's focus on the issue at hand, not how we call it. We can save that for the report."

"It's obvious that Ba'al's cloning people," Catra said. She leaned forward and peered at the bare belly of the man in the pod before her. "And humans, not Jaffa. There's no symbiont pouch."

"These seem to be humans," Carter agreed. "But we can't assume he's not cloning Jaffa as well - we don't know."

"Or Horde clones," Adora added. "If he can clone humans, he can probably also clone Clones… err, you know what I mean."

"Yes." Jack nodded. "But does he have the tech to copy and implant memories?" That was the key question. Without that kind of tech, Ba'al would have to get his clones taught whatever skills they needed the hard way. If he could just copy the skills and experience as well as the bodies, though…

"They would have had to create the technology from scratch," Carter replied. "Horde Prime restricted it to his flagship. They

wouldn’t even have had examples to reverse-engineer. But we don’t know what kind of technology Ba’al has access to.”

“If all he needs are warm bodies, he can just use mature symbionts to take over the cloned bodies,” Glimmer said. “They would have that genetic memory. But they would also have the original’s ambition.”

“They would try to topple Ba’al and tear each other apart,” Sha’re said.

“So, we don’t have to fear an army of mini-Ba’als in cloned hosts, good.” Jack nodded. “But we might still be dealing with an army of clones.”

“Even without a way to implant skills into a clone’s mind, they could still be useful,” Glimmer said. “There are a number of tasks you don’t need too much training for.”

“But those aren’t really crucial skills for the war,” Catra objected. “If he has to teach new clones everything, he needs a lot of teachers and trainers and a lot of infrastructure. Unless he just wants warm bodies to launch suicide attacks…” She blinked.

Jack glanced at the pods again and cursed. If Ba’al was cloning slaves…

“He would have no qualms sacrificing cloned slaves for even a meagre advantage,” Sha’re said. “The simpler the task, the fewer resources it would take to get a clone trained. And the fewer the cost of sacrificing them.”

They’d have to prepare for suicide attacks. Watch out for fake surrenders. Suicide bombers hiding amongst other slaves. Jack cursed again.

“He wouldn’t have to care about the health of his slaves,” Carter said. “If training a new clone is cheaper than the cost of protective gear…” She glanced out of the container, at the warehouse’s front.

“But that makes no sense!” Entrapta protested. “Even if Ba’al would only teach clones the most basic skills, it would still take years for them just to learn a language! And the other skills they need to survive! Between growing the clones and housing and teaching them, they represent a significant investment! Throwing that away for basic menial labour or… something else… doesn’t make any sense!”

“The snakes might not care much if it is economical,” Jack pointed out. “They’re not the most rational ones.”

“No, you’re right,” Sha’re said. “If he’s cloning slaves - and those bodies don’t look like they are meant to fight - then he either needs more slaves and doesn’t mind waiting years for them to be useful for his goals… or he has a way to teach them.”

“Great.” Jack looked at Carter and cocked his head at the pod. “Can you find out what’s what?”

“According to our scans, it’s a cryogenic pod keeping a single person in stasis,” Carter replied. “The body itself… looks like a normal human body. No sign of a symbiont or any implants. Or any other alteration to the brain.”

“Well, the elasticity of the brain matter is a bit higher than usual for its age,” Entrapta added. “But if we want to find out what Ba’al is doing to the clones, we need to get more and better data.”

“Well, let’s look around for more intel, then,” Jack said. That was what they were here for, after all.

*****

Adora nodded. They could analyse what this meant later - once they had more intel. And once they were back with the fleet. But first… “Can we get samples from the people where without waking them up?”

“We would have to open the pods for that,” Sam said. “And that would start the process to revive them.”

And that would let the guards know that someone had sneaked into the base.

"According to our scanner, they are identical in all categories we can check without taking samples," Entrapta added. "Though that excludes an actual genetic analysis."

"Did you get all the data from the pods?" Adora asked.

"Yes! We downloaded the entire log of the pod," her friend replied.

"And we have the cargo manifest. It doesn't list the origin, but we might find that once we correlate the information with more data points," Sam said.

Adora nodded curtly. "Let's go then. We need more information about the production here. And the people working here." They had to know if Ba'al was killing off his slaves and replacing them with clones. Among other things, of course.

"And if a slave would be missed if they vanish," Catra said. Adora looked at her, and she shrugged. "They might know things we won't find in the databanks if we interrogate them thoroughly."

"You mean if we debrief them," Glimmer said.

"Thoroughly." Catra flashed her fangs.

Adora didn't quite roll her eyes. "Let's be cautious."

They checked outside, then left the container again - after a last thorough scan of it and its contents as well as taking material samples of both the container and the pods, in case that would give them clues about its origin.

The side entrance they had planned to take wasn't guarded, and the camera covering it was easily dealt with. But they still had to cross about fifty yards of roads and empty spaces to the main administration building. Melog's illusions wouldn't be able to

completely cover them over such a distance. They would have to make sure no one was watching the area too closely. “We need a distraction,” she said, then used her communicator to call Bow. “Is there a shuttle or ship coming in soon?”

“Nothing on our sensors,” Bow replied.

“Then we need to make a distraction,” Catra said. “Can you sabotage something? Without it being obvious?”

Adora saw Sam and Entrapta exchanging glances. “We can manipulate the security system, but that might draw attention,” Sam said. “It’s not very likely, but we cannot exclude the possibility that they will suspect something.”

“Wouldn’t the first time the snakes were paranoid,” Jack added. “But we’ll have to take the risk.”

“Yes,” Adora agreed. “Simulate a glitch or something that raises an alert.”

“Alright!” Entrapta nodded enthusiastically, and she huddled with Sam over the laptop.

After a few minutes, both got up. “We’re ready,” Sam reported.

“Melog’s ready too,” Catra said.

“Do it!” Adora told them.

A few seconds later, a siren went off in the area on the other side of the route, and everyone started running out of the door and toward the next building. Adora took the lead but made sure she didn’t leave the others behind - that would strain Melog’s illusions even more.

They reached the administrative building just as the alarm ended and huddled close to the wall next to the door. There, it was easy for Melog to make them look like part of the building, and

Entrapta hacked the door and the building's security system while Sam kept an eye on the sabotaged system.

"The corridor behind the door is clear," Entrapta said after a few minutes. "And there's an empty room nearby we can hide inside."

"Good. Melog's getting a bit strained covering so much," Catra said. "And I don't hear anyone inside either."

Adora nodded. "Let's go."

Another quick dash later, everyone was inside a small storage room with empty shelves lining bare stone walls.

"It's designated as an archive according to the building's system," Entrapta explained. "But there's nothing to be archived yet I think."

"No marble, no gold decor, not even some fancy drapes… Ba'al must be strapped for cash. Or just miserly," Jack commented.

"We could only hope so," Daniel said. "But…"

"It's an administrative, not a representative building," Sha're finished for him. "There's no need to spend money on the offices of the workers running this base. Though the commander's office and quarters will be far more elaborately furnished."

"Quiet!" Catra hissed. "I hear someone walking toward us."

Everyone moved to the wall, and Melog once more covered them in an illusion. Half a minute later, Catra spoke up again. "They went through the door."

Adora sighed, relieved. "Now - can you hack the databanks from here?"

"No. They aren't connected to the security system," Entrapta explained. "We need to get to a console, the computer core or the

location of the databanks. Though those should be next to the computer core for best performance."

"So… is there an unused console somewhere?" Jack asked.

"Yes," Entratpa replied after a moment, eyes on her tool. "But it's in a room with active consoles."

"Great. The computer core it is, then," Jack said. "Where is it?"

"In the basement."

"Figures. Ba'al is a fan of the classics, isn't he?"

That must be a reference to something from Earth culture, Adora thought.

Before she could ask, though, Sam suddenly snapped: "The base commander ordered a complete sweep of the base, sir. The garrison has been put on alert."

Both Jack and Catra cursed loudly.

*****

Had she made a mistake when she engineered the sensor glitch? Samantha Carter couldn't say. Given Ba'al's reputation, it wasn't out of the question that the base commander might react with a full alert to every malfunctioning sensor. Or he might just assume the worst since the base was new, but not that new; faults from construction should have been fixed, and equipment failing from constant use shouldn't be happening.

But whatever the reason, the base was on full alert, and squads of Jaffa were gathering to search for intruders. The group had to find a way to evade them before they were found. And it was up to Sam and Entrapta to do it - they were the ones responsible for hacking the system.

“Can we reach the core thingie before the Jaffa fill the building?” the General asked.

Sam quickly checked the different feeds from the hacked security systems covering the base. “They are converging on the shipyards - and on this building, sir.”

“Do we hide here and let them finish their search?” Glimmer asked, looking at the door.

“Will they finish their search?” Catra snorted.

“Depending on the commander of the base, they might order their warriors to search until they find an intruder - or until an alternate explanation for whatever triggered this has been found,” Teal’c said.

“Now that they have launched a search, they need to provide results, or they will look foolish,” Sha’re added.

“Well, we should get moving then so we have something to show for if we have to fight our way out,” the General suggested. “Besides Adora turning the base into a flower field or something.”

“I only did that once!” Adora protested. “The other times, it was Perfuma!”

“Sir!” Sam spoke up. “We’re running out of time!”

“Then let’s start running. Keep an eye on their positions, Carter.”

“Yes, sir.” Keeping track of so many squads by flipping through feeds would be hard, but she had no choice. If only they had finished the surveillance bot project which would have automated that, but the failure rate had been too high for Sam’s standards.

“They’re searching the computer system as well,” Entrapta reported as they rushed to the door - she could carry herself with her hair and focus on her computer. “So far, they haven’t detected

us, but we can't exactly leave backdoors open if they're actively looking."

That would give away that there were intruders on the base. "Keep from being noticed," Sam said as they rushed down the corridor. "The guards in the entrance haven't moved yet."

"You block the exits, then go in and search." The General opened the door ahead of them, revealing the staircase. "Let's use that time."

"The computer core is in the second basement floor," Sam reported. And the first squad had taken position at the side entrance. That left a backdoor… no, also covered. Well, if they had to, they could just cut their way through the walls. Or blow a hole into them. But being found would mean they failed their mission.

"First basement floor clear," Sam reported after a second of flipping through feeds."

"They're checking the sensor routines," Entrapta reported. "We can still look through the feeds, but we can't alter them now without them noticing."

That made things harder.

They reached the second basement floor. Sam checked the feeds again. "There's a patrol in the main core room."

The General cursed. They could take the squad out, but, again, that would expose their presence.

"Can we access the data lines somewhere?" Catra asked.

That was a possibility. Sam quickly checked the floor maps and contrasted them with the system's architecture. "We can go through the ventilation ducts. They double as cable tunnels in some areas."

"Oh!" Entrapta perked up. "Yes, that's a very nice way to travel!"

Before anyone could say anything, she moved ahead, past the closed door, and her hair reached up to remove a grill from an opening, then pulled herself inside.

Catra cursed and jumped up, quickly sliding into it as well in one smooth motion. “Don’t rush off!” Sam heard her hiss before Melog followed her.

Adora looked at the others. “Well… Entrapta is the expert here. She spent days in the Horde ventilation ducts once.”

Sam had heard the story, as had the others.

“Let’s go!” Adora continued, hoisting up Glimmer without showing any effort before turning to the others.

Sam was the sixth in, after the General, before Daniel and Sha’re, with Teal’c and Adora, their largest members, bringing up the rear. She had some trouble moving with her computer out in front, but she managed - and she couldn’t take her eyes off the camera feeds. If they were caught in the ducts…

A few minutes later, they were deep in the maze of ducts, still following Entrapta. They had passed several cable bundles before Sam, her attention on tracking the sweep of the base, realised that they were headed to the computer core room.

The computer core room with the guards inside.

Not that it mattered - dozens of Jaffa were now searching the building. The entire base must have been mobilised.

A message flashed on her screen.

I’m at the core room! The guards aren’t looking this way!

Sam clenched her teeth and hoped Melog had Entrapta covered since she knew what her friend would do.

*****

“I can reach the console from here… I think. Just need to stretch a bit…”

“Get back!” Catra hissed, clenching her teeth while she tried to keep Entrapta from doing something stupid.

“But it's right there!” came the whispered complaint.

“Let Melog take a look first, so they can cover your hair,” Catra said.

“Oh. Right.”

Sorry.

Sorry? What were they sorry… Oh, that! Catra winced when Melog pushed past her, almost flattening her in the process. The ventilation ducts weren't that big. “You're heavier than you were before,” she whispered when her friend had gotten in front of her. “Too many treats.”

Denial.

She snorted, softly, then whispered: “Watch out, Entrapta, Melog's coming through.”

“What? Oh!”

In front of Catra, Melog squirmed their way past Entrapta. It was a bit more difficult - Entrapta was shorter than Catra, but not quite as slender. And her hair didn't help. Fortunately, Melog didn't get tangled up in it.

Done.

In front of Catra, the duct suddenly looked empty.

“Oh! Nice! If only a stealth field would work like that!”

Focus, Entrapta, Catra thought. They needed information, not inspiration right now. She resisted the urge to crawl forward,

through the seemingly empty vent, until she could peer into the room ahead. Melog and Entrapta were invisible, not gone. She would only disturb either, and at this point, that could be critical.

But she really wanted to. To do something, anything, other than waiting and feeling useless, trapped in a ventilation duct while others acted. She'd be almost glad if they were detected, and she'd have to claw some… No, she wouldn't be glad. This mission was too important. No matter how frustrating it felt.

Finally, after what felt like ages, she heard Entrapta whisper: "Almost done! There is more data than expected, but I should be able to…"

"Enemy reinforcements arriving," Sam reported through the communicator."

Catra gasped and focused on her ears. Yes, she could hear footsteps in lockstep. Then she heard the door open.

"Search the room!"

"We've been guarding the door all day. No one got past us."

"We've got our orders."

"You can see that it's empty!"

Catra heard a smack, metal against flesh. Someone didn't like backtalk.

"Search the room!"

And the footsteps fell out of step. Three, four people walking around the room. Where Entrapta was trying to download the computer's data.

Close.

Well, no shit, Catra thought.

Entrapta didn't say anything. Good - from the sounds of it, at least one Jaffa guard was close enough to hear them whispering in the ducts. So, they just had to wait until…

Catra heard a curse, followed by the sound of metal striking metal.

“What did you do?”

“Something tripped me!”

Oh, for…!

“I don't see anything.”

“I didn't trip over my own feet - it was a rope! I felt it!”

Catra's ears twitched - metal scraping over concrete. They must be running their staff weapons’ shafts over the floor.

Up in air now.

Good.

“Nothing.”

“I know what I felt.”

“There is nothing, clumsy fool!”

“But…”

“Do you think the air from the vent tripped you?” A scoff followed.

Catra tensed. If they checked the ducts… they were hidden behind Melog's illusions, but the grill covering the vent was missing…

“The room is clear. Move on to the next objective!”

She heard the steps move further away, followed by the door opening and closing again.

“So much time spent to check what everyone could see with a glance!”

“What do you expect from fools who trip over their own feet?”

Laughter from the remaining guards followed. They acted like Catra would have expected from Horde soldiers in the same situation. And if Jaffa had this attitude toward each other, what did they think of the clones following Ba'al? It was something to keep in mind, a potential weakness that could be exploited.

Though not now. Now they had to get the intel they were here for.

“Got it!”

Back.

Back? Catra cocked her head, then grimaced when she felt Melog’s hindpaw touching her face. Ah, that.

Once again, Melog squeezed their way past Catra.

“Just fixing the grill and I'll join you!” she heard Entrapta whisper, followed by soft metallic noises. “Done!”

“We’re done. We need a safe room to regroup,” Catra reported over the communicator.

“Follow me,” Adora replied.

She must have picked a room in advance, probably with Sam's help, Catra guessed. One which the Jaffa had already searched.

The stench reached her nose quite a bit before she reached the room. “The garbage storage room? Seriously?” she hissed as she lowered herself down from the ventilation duct.

“It's only used by the workers, and they're barred from the building until the search is over,” Adora defended herself.

“It’s not that bad,” Glimmer chimed in.

“Not that bad for people whose noses are only there so their glasses don't fall off their faces,” Catra shot back. It stank!

“As long as the walls don't suddenly start to try to crush us, I’m fine,” Jack said.

“I don't think they will do that - I don't detect any presses that would be able to move those walls,” Entrapta replied.

“Ah… thanks. That's reassuring.”

“So, what data did you get?” Adora asked.

“Oh, lots!” Entrapta beamed. “The production schedule, full guard and worker roster, transport schedule, maintenance… Basically, everything the administration here needs. No blueprints, though - for those, we need to get into a shipyard.”

Catra nodded. So, that would be their next objective.

*****

Jack O’Neill knew that the administrative data would allow the spooks back home to ferret out a lot about the ships being built here through thorough analysis but to get the actual blueprints… that would give the Alliance a huge advantage in any future confrontation. And, maybe, even a few designs to copy. So, he nodded. “Alright. Let’s go and steal the blueprints. Might be useful if we need to stop a Death Star.

“Indeed.” Teal’c nodded with such a serious expression, Jack couldn’t tell if his friend had gotten the joke or not. It would be just like Teal’c to pull Jack’s leg by acting as if he hadn’t gotten it.

"I don't think they're building a Death Star here. The slips could be used to build components, but you'd have to assemble them in space, and we've seen no sign of any orbital construction going on. And it wouldn't make much sense not to build such yards in the same system you're building the Death Star, to save you the transportation effort. And we haven't seen the transport ships necessary to lift such huge parts from ground to orbit, either, so it would probably be more efficient to build everything in space from the start, although that depends on how many space-rated workers you have, I guess. Of course, the Clones would know how to build things in space and qualified for such work since their fleet trains do the same, so…"

"... there's no Death Star being constructed here," Catra cut off Entrapta.

"It's very unlikely, yes."

Of course, that didn't mean Ba'al wasn't constructing some superweapon somewhere else. Though would he build such shipyards instead of focusing everything on the superweapon? Megalomaniacs loved their superweapons. On the other hand, he probably needed escorts for it, and such yards would also serve as a way to hide his actual project by making spies and saboteurs focus on them… Maybe that was why the yards were so close to Alliance space? Jack would have to bring that up with the analysts back home. But now, they had a shipyard to plunder.

"Alright. Let's see how we can reach the shipyards from here without starting another search," Catra said.

"We could wait until the search is over," Sha're suggested. "At that point, the guards will be tired and convinced there aren't any intruders around and so won't be paying as much attention as during the search."

That was a good point, but waiting for hours - or even longer; who knew how paranoid the base commander was? - would tire them out as well. "Waiting will be a pain," he said.

“We can’t hack the systems to create a distraction,” Carter said. “Another such incident would confirm our presence to the base commander.”

“But can you hack the system to hide us from the sensors?” Jack asked. That alone would be a big help in getting to the shipyards - and, not to forget, out of the base afterwards.

“That should be possible,” Carter replied after sharing a glance with Entrapta. “But we’d still have to avoid being detected by the patrols.”

“We could have Melog make us look like a patrol,” Catra suggested. “As long as you can make sure that there are no records for them to analyse later and realise that there were too many guards around at the same time.”

“We can do that!” Entrapta said. “No sweat!”

Jack glanced at Carter. Entrapta was sometimes a bit too optimistic, but his former second-in-command nodded, so that was a valid plan.

“Let’s do that,” Adora said. “Check the cameras so you can tell when we have a window of opportunity.”

“Alright!” Entrapta bopped her head and went over to Carter to peer at her laptop.

With Melog and Catra on lookout duty, that left the rest of them to wait.

Jack wasn’t a stranger to waiting. Every soldier was familiar with it - hurry up and wait, and all. It still grated on his nerves. Not that he’d show it, of course - he made a point of yawning and taking a nap. Maybe he should mention that he forgot his Game Boy… No. That might be overdoing it. And if his troops heard about it, they might think that was acceptable for them as well.

“I think we got a window here, sir,” Carter said after fifteen minutes. “If the patrols follow the same pattern.”

“Which they have for the last two cycles,” Entrapta added.

“But we need to get into position now, sir,” Carter went on.

“Then let’s go!” Adora stopped pacing and headed to the door, where Melog and Catra were also up.

They quickly made their way to the side entrance - no guards in the vicinity, not after the building had been ‘cleared’ - and gathered there, waiting for Carter, who had her eyes glued to her laptop, to give the signal.

She held up a hand, using her fingers to count down.

5… 4… 3…

Suddenly, she looked like a Jaffa warrior in full armour. Jack managed not to wince at the sight.

2… 1… Go!

Adora took point, opening the door, and they filed out, marching in step. Or tried their best - Jack really hoped no Jaffa decided to stop them to berate them for not moving sharply enough.

But they managed to reach the closest shipyard without anyone calling them out - or shooting at them - and then entered the office building next to the open slip. They had to wait a nerve-wracking minute before Carter and Entrapta had found another hiding spot, but no one bothered or even saw them, at least Jack hadn’t noticed anyone.

He still didn’t relax even after they entered what apparently was an unused lounge overlooking the slip.

A very luxurious lounge.

“Someone really likes their comfort when inspecting the shipyard,” Jack commented. “Probably Ba’al himself.” He blinked, then grinned. “Let’s check the bar - I’m sure that would give us great insight into his character!”

“Jack! Are you trying to steal his booze?”

“Of course not!” Though if he thought he could get away with it without compromising the mission, Jack would do it in a heartbeat. Just the bragging rights alone would make it worth it.

*****

“Don’t steal the drinks,” Adora said. “That would give us away.”

“They also might be poisoned,” Catra added. “Either as an assassination attempt on Ba’al or by himself as a trap for his enemies. He might even use a poison he was immune to so he could poison someone while sharing a drink.”

Adora didn’t know if her lover was serious, but she wouldn’t put it beyond a System Lord like Ba’al to do such a thing.

Jack pouted at that, narrowing his eyes at the bar. “That sounds like him. In that case, we should take a few bottles as a gift for some acquaintances.”

Adora frowned at him for that. He shouldn’t joke about that. Catra laughed, and she frowned at her as well. She shouldn’t encourage him.

They weren’t here for that, anyway. “Can you access the yard’s computer from here?” she asked Sam and Entrapta.

“We’ll check!” Entrapta nodded.

“We have to be careful, though, in case this is a trap as well,” Sam added.

I would say that sounds a bit far-fetched, but since Ba'al has his deliveries cleared with nerve gas…" Daniel shrugged.

"We'll be careful!" Entrapta's hair flew out and started probing the console near a seat with enough gold plated to its surface to outshine some thrones Adora had seen.

She turned to eye the windows. They were polarised, so those working on the slip below couldn't see inside, but Adora couldn't help feeling exposed. After the poison incident and then the alert, she was on edge.

As was Catra. Adora's lover was putting on a good front, sprawling in a leather seat to the side as if she had no care in the world, but Adora could tell from the way her tail and ears moved. And from Melog's colour, of course. But that was kind of cheating.

"OK! We're in! And no trap - no alert, at least!" Entrapta's announcement interrupted Adora's thoughts. "Let's get the data we want!"

Hair tendrils whipped around, making Adora take a step back out of reflex. Sam, though, didn't even twitch, eyes glued to her laptop.

"Oh… those are the blueprints… Ha'tak, looks like a standard model… and there's the improved one! Look at those engines!"

Adora cocked her head but she couldn't see the screen from her spot.

"Ah. That's three per cent more acceleration," Sam said.

"Not bad! But we're still faster. Oh, look at that blueprint!"

"A Ha'tak with full Horde technology?" Sam sounded impressed. And worried.

With good reason - a ship the size of a Ha'tak, with Horde technology, would be a flying fortress. A *very fast* flying fortress.

“It’s all standard Horde technology, though - nothing improved. And they didn’t even adapt the engines; they adapted everything else,” Entrapta complained.

“They might not have the scientists and engineers to adapt the new technology,” Sam speculated.

“Not *yet*,” Jack said.

“Training people to that level takes a lot of time, sir. But they should be able to recruit clones from their fleet,” Sam replied. “They should be familiar with their own technology.”

“Familiar enough to improve on it?” Jack sounded sceptical. “I used a lot of gadgets in the force and never rebuilt one. Did some unofficial modifications to my gun, but that’s not the same.”

He was correct, but they couldn’t count on having such an advantage. “We can’t underestimate the enemy,” Adora said. “They only need one smart scientist to develop better weapons for their fleet, then they can build it.”

“It’s not that simple in practice, but essentially yes,” Sam agreed. Mostly.

“Can you sabotage their blueprints? Without being obvious?” Jack asked.

“If they compare them to the original, wherever it is, they’ll notice any changes,” Sam explained.

“Can you change them so it looks as if those who created the original blueprints did it?” Catra asked.

That was a rather… ruthless way to sabotage Baal’s research and development.

“Not with any degree of certainty,” Sam said.

"Not worth the risk then. Though what about adding something? Like a trigger? Something that wouldn't show up until we use it, so they have no reason to check their blueprints?" Jack wasn't giving up on his idea. "Maybe a locator?"

"Hm. Leaving it changed would be a risk, but we might be able to change it and then remove any traces. That would mean we had to limit it to the ships here, though," Entrapta said.

"Three super-Ha'taks sabotaged seems good enough for me," Jack said. "By the time they can start on more of them, we probably are at a point where that won't really matter any more."

That could be taken in a few ways. Adora chose to take it in an optimistic way. "Do it," she told Entrapta and Sam. "Just being able to track their movements will be a great advantage for us."

That done… Adora turned to the others. "Now we need to find a way to sneak out," she said.

*****

"We can call in Bow. He can hover the stealth shuttle above this building, and we board it under cover."

Samantha Carter nodded in agreement with Catra's suggestion. It was a simple plan with a high probability of success. But she had to focus on sabotaging the ships being built here before they could leave. Adding a locator beacon would need her to have it installed on the slip without anyone realising it. That meant it had to arrive inside a finished component to minimise the risk of anyone realising what was going on. There wasn't a big chance that the slaves working here would notice something amiss by installing an additional component, but it was best to minimise the risk as much as possible.

She quickly searched the copied data. She needed a component close to the hull and with an internal power source so the locator beacon could operate. Independently and send out a signal. The beacon itself would need to have an FTL communicator built in so

it had the necessary reach. And a navigation system to track the ship's course… no, better just have it tap into the navigation system of the ship. However, that limited the potential modules even more. A direct line to the ship's computer, close to the hull… "We have to alter the ship's sensor packs," she said.

"Yes! Well, we could add an entire new module, but that would be more difficult and more easily found," Entrapta agreed.

Sam checked the data until she found the factory complex where the sensor modules were assembled. They needed to use an automated process - anything involving an actual worker was too prone to catch the attention of the staff. "Alright. We need to alter this step."

Entrapta nodded. "Add a few more steps for the beacon… but that will slow down production. They might notice that."

Right. At the very least, they might investigate such a 'glitch'. Especially after today's alert. So… "Can we optimise the procedure to compensate?" Sam asked.

"We can, I think - the whole setup looks a bit inefficient. But we'd have to restore the original routines afterwards."

"Yes?" Sam looked at her.

Entrapta pouted. "That feels wrong!"

"They're our enemy," Sam said. "Think of it as sabotage."

"Well… Oh! We could prepare some sabotage here as well!" Entrapta perked up. "If we're already manufacturing beacons and altering the core programs, we can make it so we can remotely sabotage the entire complex! We could repurpose the munition factory to blow itself up! Although that would endanger the workers, I fear."

"Watch out for mission creep," the General suddenly cut in. "Just stick with the locator beacons. We can always send another group

to sabotage or bomb the factory."

That was true, especially with superior stealth technology. Although once they used stealth shuttles for that, the Goa'uld would know about that and react accordingly, so that was best used as a mass attack to exploit the element of surprise.

"We'll limit our mission to placing the locator beacons, sir," she said.

"Good."

Sam went back to hacking the computer core of the factory while Entrapta took care of the routines they needed altered - she had more experience with setting up factories, anyway. She had to be careful, though - whoever had been checking the security system's computers might be watching the other systems as well. But they already had a backdoor here, so…

After about ten minutes, she was done. And so was Entrapta. Actually setting up the swap, and the timer to undo the changes, took longer than that, though, but finally, they were done.

And so was the exfiltration plan. They would board the shuttle from the roof of the shipyard, hidden by Melog's illusion and a couple of large vents. There was still a chance that someone might spot them - Melog's illusions were not perfect when out in the open like that, and the stealth field couldn't cover the open ramp, but…

"Did you trip another alert?" Catra hissed.

"What? No!" Sam replied, then checked. "No, the system load is normal."

"They're calling up all Jaffa again," Catra said.

And, indeed, the camera feeds showed it - all the Jaffa currently resting were rushing out of the barracks, and the Jaffa on the walls were moving to the heavy weapons.

“That is not an intruder alert,” Teal’c said in a calm voice. “You can see the squad leaders checking the appearance of their warriors’ armour. They are forming an honour guard.”

Oh. That meant…

“Ba’als coming here?” The General grinned in a familiar way.

“What was that about watching out for mission creep?” Catra asked.

“Oh, come on - that’s not mission creep. That’s a target of opportunity!” he protested. “We can leave any time, but we can’t waste this opportunity!”

Sam couldn’t argue that.

*****

The Clones Question Part 7

Ba'al's Base, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra looked at the screen, which showed the base's guards lining up to form an honour guard. They made a good job of it, as far as she could tell through the cameras. Better than most Horde units would have been able to do on short notice. Only cadets were generally ready for an inspection at a moment's notice.

"Do you think it's Ba'al?" Adora asked. "Would he do a surprise inspection in person?"

Catra shrugged. Ba'al might not announce his travel schedules in advance just to avoid ambushes and assassinations, but she knew from experience that surprise inspections kept your troops sharp, though only if you kept the focus on things that mattered, such as readiness and supplies, not how good they were at standing at attention.

"He most certainly would," Sha're said. "He wouldn't completely trust even his closest subordinates. This base here contains a shipyard and factories - a plotting underling could use this to build up their own force."

"And try to turn the clone fleet in the system," Catra added.

"Turning anyone against their god, especially new converts, is quite difficult, as we found out," Daniel pointed out.

"The base commander is a Jaffa, so the odds of him betraying his god are very low," Teal'c added.

"But Ba'al can't depend on that," Glimmer said. "Or won't."

"Indeed."

"The sensors caught a Tel'tak approaching, sir," Sam reported.

“That would be our surprise guest,” Jack said. “Can you track the ship’s course back to its origin, Carter?”

“It did not come from any of the frigates in the system, sir. It dropped out of hyperspace a distance away.”

“I don’t think Ba’al flew the whole distance in that ship. He probably has at least one Ha’tak with a Stargate nearby, so he can quickly come - and go,” Catra said. A Tel’tak had a stealth generator, which made it a good ship to escape an attack - at least if your enemy didn’t have the sensors to see through that - but it was a rather small ship, neither impressive nor luxurious. She didn’t think Ba’al would spend days or even weeks in one.

“That would be a good compromise - no direct access to the planet through a Stargate, but it can still be reached relatively quickly,” Sam said.

“It’s easier to hide the entire system that way, too,” Sha’re added.

“He probably took this planet's Stargate for that,” Entrapta said. “Since the planet doesn't have magic, it must have had a Stargate when the First Ones started charging the Heart of Etheria.”

“Probably.” Jack nodded. “But now, let’s see who is arriving.”

Everyone crowded around the screen to watch the ship come in to land on the designated space. It threw up some dust as it set down, but the assembled guards didn’t even flinch as far as Catra could tell. Well, they weren’t that good at keeping spies and saboteurs out, so they had some use, at least.

The ship’s ramp was lowered, and four Jaffa stepped out, staff weapons ready, and looked at the assembled guards.

“Now, those look tougher than the rest,” Jack commented.

“Those would be Ba’al’s personal guard,” Teal’c confirmed. “Though I do not see his Prime.”

Those guards were tall - not as tall as Adora when she was She-Ra, but almost as tall and buff as Teal'c. And they looked experienced as well. Still, Catra was sure she could take them if she had to. Pretty sure, at least.

"And here's the main act."

A human - a Goa'uld; the eyes gave it away - walked down the ramp, and the base commander dropped to his knees, followed by the honour guard.

"If that's Ba'al, then he doesn't go for as much bling as the other System Lords," Jack commented.

"We don't know how his host looks," Sha're said. "But the reception… I doubt that any of his underlings would be allowed as much respect."

"Our lipreading routine says they're calling him Ba'al. And a number of other titles," Entrapta piped up.

Catra flashed her fangs in a grin and looked at Jack.

He matched her expression. "Time to bag us a System Lord."

*****

This time, the damn snake wouldn't escape! Jack O'Neill was dead tired of missing their target!

"But what if that's a trap?" Glimmer asked.

"They're calling him Ba'al," Jack replied. "I don't think Ba'al would use himself as bait for a trap." Snakes were cowards. But then again, would he be using such a small ship and so few guards?

"He could be using a double." Glimmer was digging her heels in, it seemed.

“A double used as a host by another snake?” Jack shook his head. “That’s a recipe for a coup.”

“But it’s a bit too convenient,” Adora objected. “We just happen to stumble on Ba’al on a recon mission?”

“We’re bound to get lucky sometimes,” Jack said. It wouldn’t be the first time. And they were due a lucky break after the recent streak of bad luck.

Catra frowned. “In any case, we need to find out more before we blow our cover over a potential decoy.”

“And how do we do that?” Adora asked.

That was a good question. It wasn’t as if they could take a blood sample and run tests - and even if they could, they didn’t have Ba’al’s DNA to check. But… Jack wasn’t the only one who looked at Melog.

“Melog says they will do their best, but they cannot make any promises,” Catra said. “They can’t read minds like you read computers.”

“It should still help. If that’s a body double, they should be nervous and resenting their role, shouldn’t they?” Glimmer sounded less sure than her words, at least to Jack.

“Yes. So, we need to get close - closer - to Ba’al to check. And we need an escape plan,” Jack said. “If we do nab Ba’al, we can’t count on sneaking away.” The snake wouldn’t enter this lounge for some privacy and send all their guards and servants away, and they couldn’t count on being able to take them all by surprise before they could raise the alarm. And, speaking of… “We also should move to another room before Ba’al arrives here.”

“Yes. Good thing we didn’t steal his booze,” Catra added.

Jack snorted. “Where’s the next best hiding spot? Preferably close to this lounge.”

“We could hide in the closest storage room, but it will be cramped, sir,” Carter replied.

A red dot marked its position on the map she displayed on the screen, and Jack memorised the route to it. “We can manage being a bit cramped.” He had suffered worse on missions. “And we need to move,” he added with a glance at the screen - Ba’al or body double, the snake hadn’t spent much time letting everyone kneel to him and was already marching toward the shipyard.

“And we should bug the place!” Entrapta piped up. Her hair fanned out, and Jack could see the tendrils reaching underneath the decorations lining the bar’s front.

“Better place it on the back, he said. “Less chance it’s going to be found there.”

“Even with a chameleon-coating?”

“Yes.”

“Alright!” The tendrils reached over the bartop.

Jack frowned, but before he could say anything, Catra was already moving to the other side of the bar.

“Looks good to me,” she reported a moment later.

“Great!” Entrapta beamed.

“Now, let’s move,” Jack said. “We don’t want to be here when Ba’al arrives.”

They moved to the door. “The hallway’s clear, but a group of servants is waiting around the corner, sir. We wouldn’t cross their line of sight, but well have to be quiet,” Carter reported.

Jack could be quiet. “Let’s go,” he whispered.

They sneaked out, hidden from sight by Melog, and reached the storage room. Jack winced slightly when he saw it - Carter had slightly understated just how cramped it would be. Which was really cramped. Especially if they wanted to leave space at the door for anyone to step inside and visually check the room. Well, they would manage.

And they would be crowded around Carter's laptop, anyway, to watch Ba'al walk through the base.

Which the snake did. It really looked like a surprise inspection. He wasn't headed to the administrative building or the shipyard, no. He went straight to the warehouse - the one inside which they had found the container with the clones, Jack remembered. And the snake did head directly to said container, too.

Interesting.

"Looks like that's a special project," Catra said. "Important enough to take priority over the shipyard."

"Maybe he does have a manpower shortage," Adora speculated.

"If he did, he would take better care of the workers he already has," Sha're disagreed. "But the workers here weren't even wearing protective gear. This has to be something else."

"Wasn't Ba'al the guy with the human sacrifices in Carthage?" Jack asked. He had read about the Punic Wars, of course, but he had focused on the military aspects. Not the religious ones.

"The reports we have are mainly Roman ones, so it's not quite clear how much of them were propaganda," Daniel said.

"Ba'al did have human sacrifices in his temples," Sha're said. "But why would he clone sacrifices when he could use the slaves too sick or old to work?"

"Well," Jack said, watching how Ba'al inspected the container without looking hurried in the least, "we might find out if they

waited for him to thaw them out."

"There's another shuttle coming on," Carter spoke up. "From the Horde force in the system."

Oh! That was even more interesting.

*****

Adora focused on the camera feed. The man on the screen acted like she'd expect Ba'al to act. Confident, arrogant maybe - though that was hard to judge from this angle, and with everyone literally bowing to him, even a humble person would have looked arrogant. Well, a truly humble person would have told the people to stop bowing, but then again, Adora knew from personal experience that even people worshipping you as a goddess might not listen to such an order. In any case, the man held himself in a not-very humble manner. She wouldn't call it strutting, it wasn't quite that, but he moved… Like Horde Prime did, she realised. A leader who thought they were a god.

But did that mean he was Ba'al? All the Goa'uld they had met so far had been arrogant like that. Granted, most of them had been System Lords or their queens, or their offspring… She blinked. Goa'uld had genetic memory. "Could that be a child of Ba'al posing as them?" They would have all of Ba'al's memories - they would be Ba'al, at least effectively.

For a moment, no one said anything. In the smaller picture on the screen, the Horde shuttle came in for a landing.

Then Sha're spoke up: "It's possible, yes. But few System Lords would risk giving their children such a role. It would tempt them to topple their parent and take over. Even Apophis, who granted his son a position of power few other System Lords would dare to bequeath on their offspring, would not have gone so far."

"Someone's always the first to cross a line," Jack muttered.

“We don't know much about Ba'al,” Daniel somewhat agreed. “And if he has a child with all his genetic memory, they would be able to pose as him without anyone else being able to tell.”

“Mainly because for all that counts, they would be him,” Sam pointed out.

Daniel nodded. “That is true, yes. I doubt a System Lord would go as far.”

“Sharing power with themselves?” Jack snorted.

Adora couldn't see that either. Horde Prime had made sure that all his clones were beneath him, far beneath him. He hadn't wanted equals; he had wanted slaves.

“That’s the Horde Commander,” Catra hissed.

Adroa looked at the screen. Her lover was right - that was the Horde Commander, wearing an ornate collar over his uniform, walking out of the shuttle, followed by four other clones.

“Is he imitating Ba'al?” Daniel said in a low voice. “The same number of guards, after arriving at the same place…”

“It would not be the first time an underling imitated their superior, but they have to walk a fine line between flattery and presumption,” Sha're said.

“It could be a power play,” Jack said. “The Horde clones are Ba'al’s most powerful force. The Commander might be subtly reminding Ba'al of that by acting like this.”

Adora shook her head. It sounded plausible, and yet… “Would he act towards his god like that?” Priest would never do that. Had never done that.

“Well, we'll see how they react - both of them are now on the way here,” Catra said.

“Great. We might get a two-for-one,” Jack commented.

“We still don't know if that's the real Ba'al,” Adora cautioned him.

“Even if it isn't, the guy probably knows a lot about Ba'al's plans,” Jack pointed out. “And the same goes for the Commander. If we can capture both, the intel would be worth scrapping the mission.”

“Especially if we can sabotage the shipyards here,” Catra added.

They were correct, Adora had to admit. If that were a double, then Ba'al would be warned and change his plans - but that would still cause setbacks and delays. And shifting gears on all levels and fronts would open opportunities for more missions and expose more of his plans. “Let's listen to their meeting and then decide if we take them out,” she said. “But we need to prepare our escape. If Bow is coming to fetch us, we need to crash the entire security system so we board the shuttle without getting shot at.” Well, they couldn't stop them from firing blindly, but that was random chance. And they needed to escape the frigates in orbit as well.

“We can do that!” Entrapta sounded eager.

“The servants are moving in. And more guards are coming,” Catra spoke up. “Some will pass by this room, so stay silent!”

Adora pressed her lips together and glanced at the door. Melog was hiding them, but… If the guards suspected illusions, they would physically check the entire room. They could only hope they didn't suspect invisible infiltrators.

On the screen, a squad of Jaffa stopped in front of their door. A moment later, their leader opened, and Adora tensed.

But the Jaffa only glanced around at the seemingly empty room, nodded and stepped out again.

Adora released her breath. It had worked. But once the Goa'uld were aware of what the Alliance could do, it wouldn't work any

more. Was capturing Ba'al or his child and the Commander worth this? No, she couldn't think like that. An advantage that could never be exploited for fear of losing it wasn't an advantage at all.

She focused on the screen again. Ba'al had arrived at the building and was headed to the lounge they had bugged. The Commander was on the way as well, though would appear later. And the servants were just finishing putting up food and drink inside the lounge.

"Cutting it a bit close, are they?" Catra muttered.

"That way, the food and drinks won't have turned stale when their god arrives," Sha're said. "The Goa'uld have punished their slaves harshly for lesser 'mistakes'."

"I'd have expected him to bring his own staff to cook his meals," Catra said.

"Some System Lords do. Others might consider that a weakness rivals might exploit and consider random chance a better protection against assassination attempts," Sha're replied.

Then everyone fell silent so they could listen when Ba'al entered the lounge.

*****

Samantha Carter knew she should have picked another spot to hide - things were a little too cramped in this room. Although she was aware that everyone would be crowding her anyway, as long as she had her laptop in front of her displaying the camera feeds. Still, so many people so close made it harder for her to do her job, which was to keep an eye on the computer systems they had compromised.

"I would have expected Ba'al to receive the Commander in a throne room, not a lounge," the General commented, leaning a bit too much forward. "Run with the whole 'divine rule' thing."

“It might be an informal meeting. Or a calculated way to honour his newest follower,” Daniel speculated as they watched Ba'al take a sip from a drink a servant handed to him right before the Commander entered.

“His four guards didn't enter,” Catra remarked. “Could be they aren't trusted by Ba'al - or the Commander doesn't want any witnesses from his fleet.”

“He bows as low as Priest does,” Adora muttered as the clone did exactly that.

Sam checked that the four clones outside the lounge were covered by a camera, then looked at the main part of the screen again. Maybe she should ask for Glimmer’s tablet to set up a secondary screen to make it easier to keep ahead of all the movement inside the base… Although Entrapta was managing that on the heads-up display built into her visor. Sam might reconsider her friend's offer to build one for herself. It did seem quite useful to keep yourself from being distracted. Like by people leaning in too close for comfort.

“Welcome, Commander.”

“Your Divine Highness.”

Sam glanced at Adora and saw that she was twitching. And Catra was snickering.

“It is my honour to report that the system remains secure, Your Divine Highness.”

“I expect nothing less. So, there were no incursions from the heretics?”

“We've been on the lookout, but we have not found any trace of the ships that managed to escape us. We also have not received any further attempts to contact us. After their fake goddess was destroyed, they must have been left leaderless - aimless, Your Divine Highness.”

"Like you were when I found you."

"Yes, Your Divine Highness."

"And yet, one would expect a Horde bereft of their goddess, fake as she was, to avenge her."

"That is not our way, Your Divine Highness. We obey and follow. We serve, but we do not lead. As soon as the Pretender was dead, they withdrew."

"Do you not lead your brethren?"

"I am merely the channel for your orders, Your Divine Highness."

"Yeah, right," Sam heard the General mutter. The snort from Ba'al that the device they had planted picked up showed that the Goa'uld didn't seem convinced, either.

"That's a schemer, alright," Glimmer added. "And Ba'al knows it."

"If that's Ba'al," Catra cautioned.

"If it looks like Ba'al, walks like Ba'al, talks like Ba'al…" the General replied.

"...it could be a good double," Catra pointed out. "Double Trouble would be able to…" She fell silent as Ba'al spoke up again on the screen.

"And my orders were to bring more of your people left drifting by the loss of your former god into my caring embrace."

"You also ordered us to secure your bases and raid your enemies, Your Divine Highness. As much as we revere you, we are but mortal and our means are limited."

It was hard to tell with the speakers of her laptop, but Sam thought there was a hint of smugness in the Commander's tone

as he diplomatically reminded Ba'al of the limits of his fleet's power.

"Bound by your decree to keep our allegiance secret, we cannot easily spread word of your grace to our brethren still drifting aimlessly following their loss. We have to find their ships using our own craft, and every ship sent out to search for them is one less ship guarding your worlds and striking your enemies, Your Divine Highness."

"We need to restore contact with the other Clone fleets we know of," Adora said. "We can't let Ba'al convert them."

"Broadcasting my offer would alert my rivals and prompt them to try and seduce your brethren with false promises of salvation."

"They cannot match you, Your Divine Highness. They can only offer empty promises. Only you can offer my people a future."

Again, the tone didn't quite match the words, in Sam's impression. But why?

On the screen, Ba'al took another sip from his drink, the massive golden cup hiding his expression.

"And I am delivering. The first test subjects have arrived on this world so you can witness that I am keeping my promises."

Test subjects? Did he mean the cloned humans? And what kind of tests was Ba'al talking about? Given his reputation, Sam wasn't certain that she wanted to know.

"I have never doubted Your Divine Highness."

"And I have a great beach property to sell to you in Colorado Springs," the General commented.

"And your trust will be rewarded. Soon, Commander, your faithful people will no longer face extinction but have their future secured - under my benevolent rule, they shall multiply once more."

Sam frowned. That sounded like… “They can't clone more Clones without Ba'al's help?” That didn't make sense, did it? Horde Prime had kept control of the main cloning factories for his Horde on his flagship, but every fleet had the medical facilities to treat their wounded, including cloning new limbs and organs, and the process was not that difficult to upscale to full clones… “He must be talking about imprinting their minds!” she blurted out.

The General cursed. “And if he can implant memories like Horde Prime used to, three guesses just what a snake will do with it.”

“Hordes of brainwashed clones - humans, Jaffa, Horde Clones - loyal to their god unto death,” Catra said with a hiss.

*****

While Ba'al went on to promise basically everything, Catra's thoughts were racing. An army of cloned soldiers, with skills and loyalty built into them. Like bots, but better. Smarter, more versatile. Willing to fight to the death, to sacrifice themselves for their leader upon command - or when they thought it was necessary. She shivered at the memory of how she had done so, on Horde Prime's command, just to hurt Adora…

She pushed the memory away, focusing on the problem at hand. Clones. And the technology to imprint skills and loyalty into them. She knew what she could've done with that kind of resources. If she had been able to use troops like that. Soldiers who didn't need to be trained for years before they could be deployed in combat. Whose numbers could be adjusted practically on the fly.

And soldiers who were faithful, loyal unto death, so fanatical that she wouldn't have had to worry about backstabbing attempts, sabotage, corruption or cowardice… Alright, that was going a bit too far. Priest proved that even fanatics were willing and ready to creatively interpret orders from their goddess. Still… “We need to stop him. Before he gets this off the ground,” she said.

“We still don't know if this is Ba'al or a double. If he can clone humans, he can clone hosts as well,” Daniel objected.

Proud. Confident. Arrogant. Satisfied.

“Well, Melog says that Ba'al feels like a System Lord should,” Catra said. “Arrogant and satisfied.” That was good enough for her.

“With their genetic memory, any symbiont would probably feel the same,” Daniel retorted.

“That would only work if Ba'al has access to a queen,” Sha're added. “We don't know if that's the case.”

“What if he can clone Goa'uld?” Adora asked.

“Then he wouldn't need a queen,” Sha're replied with a grim expression.

Catra didn't think that would be a big deal. Snakes already could spawn so many larvae, being able to clone them only mattered for those System Lords who didn't have a deal with a queen. And even if Ba'al didn't have access to a queen, having a Horde fleet fighting for him would probably tempt every ambitious queen to join him. So… Her ears twitched, and she held up a hand. “Shhh!”

“...and now we will test the first heralds of a new age for your people.”

“Yes, Your Divine Highness.”

The Commander sounded like some of the Force Captains Catra had known. The ones who had been plotting behind her back. But if she could see it, a System Lord who was thousands of years old would have seen it as well, wouldn’t he? Of course, it was also obvious that as soon as Ba'al could clone more Horde clones, the Commander would be the first to end up replaced by a better version…

“They're going to leave the lounge,” Adora stated the obvious.

It would be a good opportunity to ambush them inside the building, hidden from view from the rest of the base. On the other hand, if they waited, they could find out just what exactly had been done to the clones in the warehouse. But that meant they would have to sneak out of this building and back to the warehouse without being noticed.

Catra glanced at Adora, then at Jack. “Hit them now?”

Adora nodded. “Sam, Entrapta - prepare to shut down the entire system, everything.”

“OK!”

“Melog, hide us - we need to get to them before they leave the building.”

Agreement.

“Alright,” Catra replied for both Melog and herself.

“And how do we get out once we have them?” Glimmer asked. “Even with the bases's systems down, people could still see us board.”

“You can teleport us out,” Adora told her.

“But… Ah!” Glimmer nodded.

Adora smiled. “We need to start showing the clones that there are alternatives to Ba'al.”

And what better way to do that than to unleash the planet's magic? Catra smirked. With a bit of luck, that would shock the Clones in the ships above them as well.

“Let’s hurry - Ba'al just finished his drink,” Jack urged them.

They moved to the door, and Catra cocked her head, listening. She couldn't hear any steps nearby, but the door wasn't that thin.

Clear.

Catra opened the door and stepped into the hallway outside, moving to cut off Ba'al and the Commander. They had eight guards with them, and a few servants.

No problem. They just had to be quick enough to finish them before reinforcements could arrive.

She quickly dashed around two corners - she wasn't going as fast as she could; she couldn’t outrun the others, or Melog wouldn't be able to cover them all, but she was quick enough. Another corner and she came upon the rear of their target.

The guards were good, at least Ba’al's, Catra had to hand them that. Two were already turning, raising weapons, shouting “Ambush!”, when she pounced on them.

But Catra was quicker, her claws tearing through the two Jaffa's throats as she dragged them to the ground with her before they could fire.

The two Clones forming the rearguard with them fired, but their shots passed over her head - and were stopped by Adora's shield.

Adora smashed into them, trampling them underfoot before slamming the Commander into the wall with a sweep of her shield.

Catra jumped, pushing off the wall, hitting the other wall, bouncing off, launching herself at Ba'al… and hit a force field. She slashed at it as she slid down, then rolled to the side, another shot missing her as the guards in the front started firing.

Between Ba'al blocking their line of fire and Adora rushing ahead, they couldn't do much to Catra, though.

And then Adora hit them, followed by Jack and Teal'c shooting them, and they couldn't do much at all any more.

With the Commander down, that left Ba'al.

*****

Jack O'Neill double-tapped a guard who had caught a staff blast but was still moving - or twitching - and then spun around, carbine rising, to aim at the snake still standing. Ba'al was firing his pain thingie at Adora, who was shielding Catra behind her. She took the full charge to the face but looked none the worse for wear.

Jack held his fire - his gun wouldn't get through the force field, and ricochets were bad news for everyone, especially inside a hallway. Alerts were sounding - people had heard the shots.

Adora swung her shield forward, pushing Ba'al, forcefield and all, back against the wall with enough force to startle him and make him stop using his torture beam. Before he could recover, the shield changed into a sword, and Adora cut his forcefield apart.

“What…”

Catra dashed forward and cut short both Ba'al’s question and his arm. The snake stared for a moment, seemingly uncomprehending, as his lower arm clattered down on the floor in a spray of blood.

Before Ba'al could start screaming, Jack drew his zat one-handed and stunned him.

“Catra!” Adora snapped. She looked angry. Then again, as close as she had been, Ba'al's blood had splattered over her chest.

“You've got magic cleaning,” Catra shot back as she bent down and started tying off the limb.

“Not that!”

“We can fix him later.”

“And we need to move!” Jack cut in.

“Several squads are moving toward our position, sir,” Carter reported. “We’ve crashed the system, but the whole base has gone on alert anyway.”

Well, shots fired next to your boss had that effect, computer or no computer.

“Get to the roof here!” Adora ordered as she picked up both Ba'al and the Commander.

“OK!” Entrapta replied.

“Bow! Come fetch us!”

“On my way!”

“Move!” Jack snapped, covering the entrance ahead of them. “This will get crowded any moment.”

Shots and staff weapon blasts rang out behind him - the first guards had reached them and ran into Teal'c.

The door in front of Jack was kicked open, and he fired a short burst at and through it at once, catching an armoured figure right behind it. The new ammo tore through the Jaffa as advertised, and the man staggered, then started to drop.

But more were coming behind him. “Incoming!” Jack yelled, firing two more bursts before ducking below a staff blast that blew a hole in the wall next to him and grabbing a grenade. “Fire in the hole!”

He threw the grenade high, lobbing it through the door, while he fell back, firing a few more rounds to keep the Jaffa from rushing them.

Then the explosion went off, Jack felt the shockwave in his chest, and dust and smoke briefly hid the doorway.

“Come on!” he heard Adora yell, followed by metal smashing into metal. “Move!”

He spun around, running after the others. Teal'c was at the corner ahead, staff weapon aimed at the hallway behind Jack, covering him. Jack ran past him, jumped over a few crumpled bodies that had been smashed and slashed, and knelt down at the next corner. “Teal'c!”

His friend fired his weapon one more time, then sprinted towards and past Jack, who laid down covering fire.

“Stairs!” he heard over the communicator.

He glanced over his shoulder for a moment while swapping magazines. Teal'c was at the stairs, with Daniel and Sha're, who was firing a zat in the other direction. The rest must have gone up the stairs already.

Time to run.

“Fire in the hole!” He threw another grenade down the hallway and then ran all-out to the stairs, throwing himself around the corner into cover a moment before the grenade blew up behind him.

“Jack!” Daniel blurted out.

“Run!”

They ran, Teal'c and Jack bringing up the rear. Another squad of Jaffa had tried to cut them off one floor above them, but Catra and the others had gone through them. Mostly Catra - they looked like someone had put them through a blender. Jack almost slipped in the blood.

Below them, more Jaffa poured into the staircase, and Jack dropped a grenade down on them before booking it.

The doors on the next floor had been welded shut, it seemed - Jack could hear someone pounding on them on the other side as he dashed past, followed by Teal'c.

Two more floors. One more squad of guards dead on the ground - two shot by staff weapons, even though only Teal'c carried one in their group, Jack noted before realising that Melog must have fooled them into shooting each other - and they reached the roof.

A roof that was being shot at from below, with heavy weapons, forcing the team to huddle down in the middle of it to avoid catching a stray blast.

“They don't seem to care much about the health of their god,” Jack commented as he joined the others.

“They must have standing orders,” Teal'c said next to him, aiming down the stairs. “With the computer system down, they could not have coordinated so quickly.”

“I can't approach with all the guns firing there!” Bow reported over the communicator.

That was bad. But they could…

“Enemy frigate moving into position above the base!” Carter interrupted his thought.

That was worse. But they couldn't just blast the base with their Commander and their god inside, so…

“They’re firing!”

What the hell?

*****

Adora gasped, staring up at the sky. The Clones were firing at their own base? Their own Commander? Their own god? How could that be possible?

“Ba'al must be a double!” Catra hissed. “Or that's treason!”

“We need to leave!” Glimmer yelled.

It didn't matter why they fired. They were on a base. A stationary target. They couldn't leave quickly enough.

As the first beams struck the base's outer walls - the first barrage was off, a distant part of Adora's brain noticed, must not have calculated the atmospheric interference correctly - time seemed to freeze as she raised her sword and reached out, feeling for that familiar pattern to cut…

She screamed as she channelled this world's magic, all of, throwing it against the beams striking down from the sky. As the magic obeyed, the beams splashed against a dome covering the entire base, some stopped outright, others, at the edges, deflected to strike the ground, throwing up shards of stone, clumps of earth and clouds of smoke as they blew craters into the area.

Adora clenched her teeth, straining under the pressure. But she would not yield. They wouldn't touch her friends. They wouldn't touch any of the helpless victims here. SHe would stand her ground.

No, she corrected herself, trembling as she stood, sword raised to the sky, that wasn't enough. She had to *stop* them from attacking.

Her eyes blazed with power as she reached out once more, magic expanding her senses, reaching out, up, into the sky, into space…

There! Directly above them, she found the enemy. A Horde frigate, beam cannons firing ceaselessly, two more frigates about to join them, more on the way…

No! The dome rose, shooting up, deflecting the beams to the side as the magic obeyed her and flew directly at the ships in orbit. She saw the first frigate starting to move, the two others slowing

down, trying to escape, but she wouldn't let them. They'd return to attack her friends and the others again.

Before the ships could flee, she struck, sending magic into the hulls, into the engines and reactors, into everything.

And they stopped. Changed. *Bloomed*.

Adora smiled as three new flowers spread their glittering petals in the sky above them, forming a triangle of life in space, leaves twisting and weaving to orient themselves towards the sun, thick stems connecting everything, reaching out to each other…

She heard Sam's voice in the background. “Three frigates are gone, sir! Replaced by… giant flowers! The other frigates have stopped their approach and are withdrawing!”

“Bow! Get us out of here before they recover!” Jack sounded worried.

“I can teleport us!”

Catra's beautiful voice joined the chorus. “Bow! Open a line to the enemy fleet and tell them to surrender or they'll suffer Adora's Divine Wrath as well!”

What? Wait! That wasn't…

Adora blinked, lowering her sword and turning toward her lover, breathing heavily as the strain from channelling so much magic finally caught up with her. “Catra! What…?”

Bow's voice rang out from her communicator - and from the speakers inside the base.

“Warriors of Ba'al! Surrender or suffer the Divine Wrath of She-Ra, Princess of Power! You only live by her grace!”

The fire from the weapon emplacements had stopped, Adora realised, though she couldn't remember when that had happened

- during her channelling the world's magic, or when the orbital bombardment had started?

She walked to the edge of the roof, to the railings holed by staff blasts, and looked down. She was glowing, she noted - surrounded by a shining halo. It would fade, she knew, but…

“Glory to Ba'al!” someone shouted, and a staff weapon hit her in the face.

“Adora!”

She didn’t even feel the explosion. Nor the dozen other shots hitting her. She simply stood there, staring, until the shots tapered out. She caught one with her blade and sent it to the side, into a part of the outer wall, and the firing stopped altogether.

Then, one by one, people started to kneel.

*****

The Clones Question Part 8

Ba'al's Base, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"The remaining Horde forces in the system have signalled their surrender."

Samantha Carter mentally filed Bow's report as she focused on restoring the same security system she had just crashed minutes before. Most of the warriors might have surrendered, but there were holdouts, and it would be a while until Alliance forces arrived to secure the base. They needed the ability to check the entire base as soon as possible to prevent sabotage attempts by the Ba'al loyalists.

"Copy, Bow. Did any ships escape?"

"Except for the frigate that jumped to hyperspace before we even called for their surrender, no."

There. Sam successfully rerouted the sensor data to an alternate core. The main sensor data processing core was still caught in a loop of cascading self-diagnosis routines that Entrapta and Sam had started in it and which proved to be harder to stop than expected. So much for improvised viruses. But now they could at least access the sensors… those that were still working, she amended her thoughts. There were blind spots in several locations where the sensors must have been burnt out after the safety limiters on the power supplies had been taken offline by another virus.

"Sensors are back online, though we lack complete coverage," she reported.

"Good work, Carter. Keep making sure that the base won't blow up around us!"

The General thought he was joking, but if Sam hadn't shut down the shipyard's automated production lines, that could have happened. A lot of machinery would have had to malfunction at the exact right time, but it would have been possible, at least theoretically. A not-unusual weakness of many Goa'uld designs.

"Ah! Look at those sneaky snakes trying to sneak by us! Teal'c, care to cut them off?"

"Yes, O'Neill."

She spent the next few minutes writing a new routine to control the power fed to the most sensitive sensors. It would reduce the sensors' effectiveness but prevent them from burning out.

"We've mopped up the holdouts in warehouse two. The clone container is secure."

"Copy, Catra. Stand by."

"We've finished the squad trying to get into our rear."

More good news. She ran another diagnosis on the sensor network… no sign of any tampering. Not from anyone else, at least. And there were no reports of any contacts.

It looked like they had managed to pull off the takeover of an entire shipyard - as long as they could hold it for a little longer, until the task force secured the system and started to land the ground forces assigned to it.

She checked the feeds.

The guards and workers who had surrendered were staying in the yard next to the barrack, watched over by Adora. She didn't like staying there, of course, while everyone else rooted out the ones who hadn't surrendered and gone to ground, but no one else could have replaced her. She was the only one who could guard so many potential enemies by herself. Sam doubted that many Jaffa or workers would want to defy Adora after she had

demonstrated her power. Of course, even if they did, Adora could handle them.

Just as Daniel and Sha’re could handle the Commander and Ba’al, should either of the two wake up from being stunned and attempt to get out of the improvised cell they had been put in.

“Alright! I’ve checked the defences twice - they are offline! And I haven’t found any self-destruct devices!” Entrapta announced. *“I’m coming back to help with the computers!”*

More good news. Now, if only the task force would hurry up and finally secure the system… She checked the long-range sensors. They weren’t as good as the Alliance’s, but they could still find Horde frigates. And if Sam had calculated the flight times and the communication lag correctly, then…

Here they came. Frigate after frigate, the task force dropped out of hyperspace and started to fan out to secure the surrendered enemy ships. Sam could see shuttles shooting away as well - those were the landing forces they were waiting for, with two frigates separating from the rest of the force to cover them.

“The task force has arrived in-system, sir,” she informed the others. Just a little bit longer.

“Great! Don’t get sloppy now, folks - we’re almost home-free. Another successful mission!”

“Technically, Jack, we failed the mission when we broke our cover.”

“Daniel!”

Sam couldn’t help snorting at the exchange - for a moment. Then, she went back to restoring the base’s computer cores.

Her work wouldn’t be done even after the base was secure, after all.

*****

“Alright. Let’s wake him up,” Catra said and leaned forward to stare at the unconscious, one-armed form of Ba’al - of his host, she corrected herself with a touch of guilt. She had cut off his arm, though he had been busy trying to hit her with that torture device mounted on it at the time, so it was really self-defence.

“I’m healing him now,” Adora said.

Catra quickly checked the restraints - all set - and glanced at the door - secured.

When she turned her attention back to the prisoner, Adora had just finished healing him, although only enough to wake him; she hadn’t regrown his arm. That probably required more magic. But he didn’t need the bandages any more.

The man didn’t try to move, and his slow breathing didn’t change.

Catra snorted. “Playing dead?”

“Neural activity detected in both the host’s brain and the Goa’uld’s brain,” Sam reported over the communicator.

After a moment, the man opened his eyes. “It was worth a try.” He raised his head and looked around - first at his restraints, then at Adora. “For someone with your power, you seem remarkably concerned about me. Do you expect me to escape my bindings and attack you with my stump?”

Catra grinned. At least, the snake had a sense of humour. She could almost respect that.

“Hello, Ba’al - or whoever you are,” Adora told him. “I’m She-Ra, Princess of Power.”

“Yes, yes, you’ve already introduced yourself to my loyal underling,” Ba’al replied. “Unlike some of my rivals, I am not in the

habit of dismissing the reports of my commanders even when they sound rather far-fetched." He looked around. "Although I do think we're missing Colonel O'Neill. I remember he was shooting at me."

Catra shrugged. It had always been a long shot to hope he hadn't noticed or recognised their friends. "It's General O'Neill now," she said, then turned to the camera covering the room. "Jack?"

A moment later, the door opened, and Jack entered the room. "How the mighty have fallen," he said with a grin once the door closed behind him.

"Don't be too hard on yourself, O'Neill," Ba'al shot back.

"I'm not the one strapped to a table in a cell."

"No, you're the general still fighting on the frontlines because your planet can't find better soldiers."

"I like leading from the front - an alien concept for you, I know." Jack shrugged. "But enough about me. Let's talk about you, Ba'al."

"Yes!" Adora nodded. "You're our prisoner. We won't kill you, but we will free your host whether you cooperate or not."

"I fear that's not something you can promise." Ba'al grinned. "But let's say I cooperate. What would be my reward? Purely hypothetically, of course."

Catra narrowed her eyes. The Goa'uld was far too cocky for someone missing an arm and any plausible chance of escape. Something wasn't right.

"You'd have access to more entertainment in your cell," Adora said.

"Oh? I have very discerning taste when it comes to entertainment." Ba'al smirked.

“We’re talking movies and books,” Jack told him.

“Sanitised, so I cannot glean any useful information from either, I suppose?” Ba’al sounded almost amused.

“You know the drill,” Jack said with a shrug.

“That doesn’t sound very appealing, to be honest. It sounds rather boring, actually.”

“Sounds like a good deal for a snake like you, actually.” Jack grinned toothily.

“Really?” Ba’al looked at Adora. “Is that your opinion as well, Princess?” he asked in a mocking tone that made Catra want to slice off his other arm.

But that would only hurt his host, she reminded herself.

Adora frowned at him. “You heard our offer.”

“I have a counter-offer. Release me, or my hostage will pay the price.” Ba’al was still smiling.

“You really think we’d let you go?”

“No, I suppose not. Well, it has been a pleasure to meet you, but I think I’ll take my leave now. Do not worry, though - we shall meet again.” Ba’al bared his teeth, nodded - or tried to, strapped to the table, it looked really awkward - then closed his eyes.

“What the…?”

“The scanners detect poison flooding the host’s body - and the symbiont’s! Their vital signs are…”

Adora was already raising her sword, sending magic at the bound man.

“...stabilising,” Sam went on in a more controlled voice.

Ba’al opened his eyes again and glanced around. “I must confess that this is a surprise. This is the first time this hasn’t worked.”

“There’s always a first time,” Jack said.

“As you can see,” Adora went on, “we won’t let you die.”

Catra flashed her fangs at him. “Feel free to try it again - she likes the exercise.” The snake had a limited amount of poison available; the more he used now, the more harmless he became.

“I think I’ll give it a pass, but thank you anyway.”

He still sounded smug, but Catra thought he was not quite as confident anymore. Unless that was an act, of course.

“So, about that cooperation…?” Jack smiled at him again.

Ba’al snorted in return. “For what undoubtedly amounts to another form of torture? I know what you Tau’ri consider entertainment.”

Catra snorted against her will, even though it wasn’t really funny. Did that mean Ba’al had prisoners from Earth? Or access to information gained from such?

Or was he bluffing? Just trying to rile up Jack? That would be quite understandable, of course.

Catra was determined to find out.

*****

Jack O'Neill really wanted to bash the man's teeth in. He knew that that would only hurt the host, another victim of the snake, and that he shouldn't abuse a prisoner, but damn was that one smug snake! Missing one arm, strapped to a table in a secure cell, surrounded by a woman who had turned his ships into space flowers, and he acted as if he was in charge - even after he had found out he couldn't kill himself and his host.

Then again, the snake was crazy; you had to be to act like suicide was a way to conduct a prison escape. Jack blinked. Or… what if the snake wasn't crazy? "Oh, I wouldn't say that. We have plenty of great movies, shows and books. Some of them would teach you a few valuable lessons."

Ba'al snorted. "I am not much for indoctrination either, General."

"Unless you're the one doing it to others," Jack shot back.

The snake jerked a little - trying to shrug while in restraints. "I prefer to think of it as educating people and showing them a better way."

Jack snorted, but he heard Catra hiss under her breath.

Ba'al had heard it as well since he turned his head to look at her. "And who are you? You are not one of Bastet's chosen. A sekhmet's claws can't cut through metal."

"I'm Catra." Jack saw her bare her teeth at the snake.

"How original." Ba'al sneered, and Catra scoffed. "You were on Saqqara."

It didn't sound like a question, but the snake could just be bluffing and fishing for information, and they wouldn't give him any. "So, about that entertainment…" Jack said. "You sure about it? It's going to be very boring in your cell without some perks."

"Oh, I do not think I will be your prisoner for very long." Ba'al smirked.

"We already showed you that you can't kill yourself. And we will free your host," Adora told him.

"It is not as if I would wish to keep him, anyway. I do not have any use for damaged goods."

Jack clenched his teeth at the reminder of what the Goa'uld did with crippled slaves. “Well, you're about to experience a similar thing. We're not going to give you a new host. But don't fret - we've prepared a nice habitat for you.”

For a moment, the snake's eyes flashed with what Jack hoped was rage. But he quickly recovered. “I do not think I will suffer such an indignity for long, though.”

“Pretty confident, are you?” Jack shot back with a scoff. “Do you really think you'll be able to escape?”

“Oh, unless your goddess here is going to spend all her time being ready to pull me back from the brink of death, I don't think you will be able to hold me for long.” He turned his head to look at Adora. “And if you do, you'll be missed by your faithful worshippers - and on the frontlines our dear General so loves.”

So, that was how the snake wanted to play things. He expected to kill himself sooner or later. Jack had met such fanatics before, in his old line of work, but they had always been followers, never the leaders. And Ba'al didn't strike him as someone who'd follow anyone. And Jack didn't think he was crazy or suicidal either. So, why was he acting like this? Was it a bluff?

“We won't let you kill yourself,” Catra said. “We can put you into stasis until we’re ready to extract you - and to remove your poison glands.”

The man's eyes widened for a moment, then glanced at Jack before settling on Adora. “You are more ruthless than I was told to expect.” His face settled in a sneering smile. “But then, there’s always a distinct difference between what we tell the faithful and what we actually do. I do have to admit, however, that your facade is better than most.”

Adora glared at him. “It is not a facade! It wouldn't be right to treat those who were fooled into following you the same as you!”

Ba'al scoffed in return. “You are not fooling anyone here, my dear. No need to pretend.”

“Is this going to be one of those ‘we are not so different’ speeches?” Jack cut in. “Because I can tell you it won't work. She-Ra's the genuine article.”

“Really?” Ba'al raised his eyebrows and smirked again. “You have caught me, and now you will make an example out of me. You will take my host, my dignity and my higher faculties from me. The details may vary, but that is exactly how any Goa'uld would treat a captured rival.”

Oh, for…! That was a low blow. Jack glanced at Adora and cursed internally. She wouldn't take this well.

And Ba'al wasn’t finished. He raised his head as much as he could with the restraints holding him down and grinned at her. “Though I have to give you points for creativity - most of my peers would leave the act of restoring their dead victims to a sarcophagus. You like to do that yourself, though, don't you? Going for that personal touch?”

Adora jerked in response, and Catra hissed again.

Damn.

*****

Adora wasn't like the Goa'uld! She wasn't a sadistic tyrant torturing her enemies and robbing them of their dignity! She was protecting and helping people! “I’m not healing you to torture you - I'm healing you to save your host!”

Ba'al laughed in her face. “So, you would let me die as long as you could save my host? How naive do you think I am?”

Adora clenched her teeth. She wouldn't hit the Goa'uld - she'd hit the innocent host, anyway. “We're not like you!”

“That's exactly what someone like me would say!”

Oh, this…!

“You don't have to take our word for it. Once we have you out of your host, you will find out for yourself,” Catra told him.

“Is that when you will present me with the choice of either letting my mental faculties degrade as I am bereft of a host until I cannot think clearly any more, or ‘cooperate’ to avoid that fate? Or will you skip the posturing and go straight to torture?” He scoffed.

“We're not going to do that!” Adora blurted out. They didn't torture their prisoners! “We won't get you a new host, that's true, but we wouldn't give you a new host anyway - we wouldn't let anyone suffer like that!”

He looked surprised for a moment before laughing again. “I cannot believe you would admit this. How did you think you could convince me to cooperate if you tell me to my face that you won't grant me even the smallest concessions I need to preserve my mind? I would rather die than suffer such indignity!”

Adora pressed her lips together. It was unfortunate that Goa'uld depended on sapient hosts to reach their own mental potential, but that didn't justify subjecting anyone to giving up their freedom and becoming a prisoner in their own body!

“Oh, stop it!” Catra rolled her eyes. “We know it's not that bad - you're not the first Goa'uld we captured.”

“And who knows, it might be good for you. Make you chill out some. Like fixing a dog.”

Adora winced at Jack's remark. That was… well, almost as bad as Ba'al's comments.

“You have done this to others?” He didn't seem to be as smug any more as he stared at Jack.

“We've got the routine down pat. There's already a nice little snake habitat with your name waiting for you,” Jack replied.

Adora shook her head. “We know what losing your host does to you. But it's not as bad as you claim.”

He scoffed, clearly angry. “That is easy to say for you - it's not your mental faculties that degrade, reducing you to an imbecile.”

“They aren't yours either!” Adora retorted. “You use your host's mind for yourself!”

Catra suddenly snorted, and Adora glanced at her lover. “You're like a thief who stole a fortune and then demands that he can keep it when he's arrested because he got used to luxury.”

That’s a really good point, Adora thought.

Ba'al must have thought the same since he didn't seem to have a comeback ready. But after a few seconds of glaring, he snorted again. “You know nothing. I am looking forward to your reaction when you find out just how ignorant you are.”

Adora frowned. It did sound like empty boasting, a defeated enemy trying to posture, and yet… she couldn't help wondering what if it wasn't?

“I'll take that as you refusing our generous offer,” Jack commented, which resulted in another snort from Ba'al.

“You can take it however you wish, General O’Neill.” He closed his eyes and let his head rest against the table.

It seemed as if he was done with them.

“I guess this interrogation has finished,” Jack said.

“Yes,” Catra agreed. She drew a zat'nik'tel and stunned Ba'al. “Let's keep him in stasis until we can get him to the Tok'ra. He's less annoying that way.”

That was a good idea. But… "We would need one of the stasis pods from the clone container for that," Adora pointed out.

"Well, we're not going to keep the clones frozen for much longer, do we?" Catra shrugged. "Entrapta should have figured out if that's safe by now."

That was true. However, they might want to move the container to a safer location for that. One with a Stargate in it. Maybe even Earth or Etheria. They hadn't decided yet if they were holding this base or moving everything useful to Alliance space. Without more information about the forces Ba'al had at his disposal, they couldn't tell if they could hold this base against an attack - they couldn't even speculate who might be in charge, what with both Ba'al and the Commander taken prisoners. If that was actually Ba'al - they still weren't a hundred per cent sure about that. He certainly had the arrogance of a System Lord, but the way he tried to kill himself…

So… "Let's go and interrogate the Commander," she said.

She hoped they had more luck with him.

*****

Samantha Carter frowned as she looked one last time at the results from the analysis of the biopsy they had taken. The preliminary analysis, she corrected herself - they would do another analysis, a much more detailed one than this one, once they got the samples to Alpha with its far more advanced instruments. But even so…

"The Goa'uld is at least several hundred years old," she said to the others in the repurposed briefing room inside Ba'al's former base.

"Isn't Ba'al supposed to be a few thousand years old at the minimum?" the General asked.

"Actually, he would have to be five thousand years old at the minimum since he was present at the Rebellion against the

Goa'uld on Earth, but one would have to take into account that he was considerably older at that point to have established himself as a leading figure," Daniel elaborated.

"So, that's not Ba'al?" Glimmer asked.

"We cannot determine that yet. The Goa'uld use of the Sarcophagus technology to rejuvenate themselves throws off our analysis," Sam explained. "We hope that the more advanced instruments and computers at Alpha can tell us more."

"And we got Loki to help there!" Entrapta smiled. "He probably would like to do something different for a change."

Sam doubted that - he had been almost single-mindedly focused on his mission to save his people as long as she had known him - but then, she wasn't that familiar with Loki. The Asgard was not the most personable scientist she knew, to say the least, and she didn't seek out his company. And since genetics wasn't her main field, he tended to be a little - or a lot, depending on the day - condescending.

But he was the best in his field, Sam had to admit that, and he would likely be able to find out if the Goa'uld they had caught was the original Ba'al. Although that might not matter much. "Even if this symbiont is too young to have been alive back then, he could still have the complete memories of Ba'al, which would render the age differences effectively irrelevant," she pointed out.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded with a smile. "Since Goa'uld have genetic memory that they can pass off to their children, they can sort of make a younger copy of themselves - and without any technology at all! It's fascinating. According to Anise, they can choose how much memory they pass on as well, if they don't want to make complete copies - I guess it would get a bit confusing if their children are actually copies, right?"

"And bloody," the General agreed. "The snakes aren't very likely to share power even with themselves. Especially not with

themselves."

"There can only be one."

Sam turned to stare at Teal'c, and she wasn't the only one. Her friend raised his eyebrow at them as if he hadn't just made a movie joke and were confused about the attention.

She shook her head with a slight smile while the General chuckled and Daniel explained the quote to Sha're and the others who were not familiar with the movie.

"...and there was a sequel, but it was not as well-received, and…"

She cleared her throat to interrupt him. "We have also analysed the identical people kept in stasis whom we have taken into our care. They are indeed clones, all the markers are there, and while we cannot be a hundred per cent certain yet, we need a more thorough examination for that, the circumstantial evidence we found indicates that they were grown using Horde technology."

"Great," Jack commented. "So, Ba'al can make copies of people."

"We haven't found any sign that they were subjected to Horder Prime's mind-imprinting technology, though," Sam went on.

"So… They are like newborn babies? When they are released from the cloning pods, I mean," Adora asked.

Bow grimaced. "Do you think they need diapers?"

"Ew!" Glimmer made a retching noise.

"I guess we know what the punishment duty for Ba'al's Jaffa is," Catra said with a chuckle.

"Well, I doubt he'd ship clones who still need to be potty-trained to this base," the General commented. "It lacks a daycare centre."

Sam shook her head. "Unfortunately, there's more."

“I knew it!” The General shook his head. “There's always more.”

Sam smiled thinly at his weak joke. “We’ve found traces of Goa'uld possession with our scans in every clone. Naquadah levels in their blood are very slightly elevated, there's microtrauma around their spinal cords that matches those from other victims… We still need to confirm it with more extensive examinations once they are released from stasis, but it seems all of them at least briefly served as a host for a symbiont.” She shuddered at her own memories of being possessed by Jolinar. How much more traumatising would it be if those were your earliest memories?

The General's expression had turned flat. Everyone else had grown serious at once as well.

“Why would they do that?” Glimmer asked.

Sam took a deep breath. This was a necessary briefing. “Hosts share the experiences of the symbiont's actions and can retain some of the symbiont's memories as well.” She knew that from personal experience. “It could, theoretically, be used as a way to implement basic skills into a host’s mind.” Likely quite effectively if the host was, for all that counted, a newborn clone with a brain devoid of actual memories.

“Oh, Hell! Ba'al doesn't need the mind-imprinting technology at all, does he? He can just use symbionts.”

“That would be our conclusion, sir, but we still need to release the clones from stasis to confirm it.”

*****

The Commander didn't look that arrogant any more, Catra found as she looked at him seated in the improvised interrogation cell. Oh, he tried to look tough and defiant, but she was familiar enough with Horde Clones to spot the signs. Oh, if they were doing this in the actual torture chamber, he'd probably be cracking already, but they were better than that. Even if she was tempted

to at least scare him with the idea for his attempt to murder Adora.

Well, time to get this show on the road - they were on a timetable. She opened the door and walked inside, ahead of Adora.

The Commander ignored her and focused on Adora. “Ah, the false goddess arrives!”

“I am no goddess!” Adora replied.

“Your followers claim otherwise.”

“I can't tell them who to worship.” Adora shrugged, though Catra knew she wasn't quite as unconcerned. Well, everyone who knew her was aware of how much of a sore point this was.

The Commander scoffed. “A transparent claim.” But he was fidgeting, Catra saw. No comparison to Ba'al's attitude. Or Hordak's. You could say a lot about Hordak, as you could about Catra, but he wasn't a coward or a fake.

And Catra was pretty sure the Commander was both. She leaned forward, both hands on the table, and unsheathed her claws so they sank into the metal. When she caught his eyes focusing on that, she smirked. “Your ships have surrendered. Your ‘god' is in our hands. The base is ours.”

He scoffed again, but his cheek twitched. “The force here might have surrendered, but not my fleet. And losing the base is meaningless for us - we don't need it!”

Nothing about his supposed god, Catra noted.

Adora hadn't missed that, either. “And what about Ba'al?”

“He will return!”

“More powerful than before?” Catra snorted. “He's no Horde Prime - and She-Ra destroyed Horde Prime.”

He stared at Adora. “You lie!”

“I don't lie,” Adora told him. “I destroyed him. I am not proud of it, but there was no other way to save everyone else. You can ask the others.”

“Your brainwashed followers, you mean!” he spat, tugging on the cuffs securing him to the table.

“No!” Adora retorted. “We would never do that to anyone - or tolerate it. We know how terrible it is.”

Catra nodded, clenching her teeth. They knew it too well. She focused on the task at hand instead of on the memories of Horde Prime. “And you know it too. You know Horde Prime did it - and that Ba'al was doing it. You don't believe that he's a god.”

He gasped, staring at her, then at Adora. “He's a god!”

Catra snorted. “We've dealt with people who honestly believe the snakes are gods. You're not like them.”

He glared at her. His “You are wrong!” was a second or two too late to convince anyone.

Adora shook her head. “Why were you following him? What did he promise you?”

The Commander pressed his lips together and avoided looking at either of them.

Time to push their advantage. “He offered to make more clones for you,” Catra said.

He jerked at that, then glared at her. And the way he ducked his head a little… Yeah, they already knew that, but this confirmed it further.

“You couldn't get the cloning pods to work properly, could you?” Adora asked softly. “Horde Prime had kept the knowledge to himself.”

The Commander bared his teeth, but his eyes moved from her to Catra to the door, then to the table and back. “We could clone people!”

“But you couldn't clone them with the knowledge they needed,” Adora said.

“And you didn't want to raise them.”

“We couldn't! They don't learn anything!” he blurted out. “They were braindead.”

Catra suppressed a wince as she drew a slow breath. So, they had tried. But without any experience in raising kids, they hadn't known what to do. And had assumed the newborn were… Shit.

“Oh, no!” Adora looked horrified.

Catra pressed her lips together. That was worse than she had thought, and she had grown up in the Horde. Much worse.

“What did you do?”

“They were braindead,” he repeated himself without looking at them.

“No!” Adora gasped, shaking her head. “You didn't…”

Catra shook her head. They did. Time to cut this off. She reached out to squeeze Adora's hand, then focused on the Clone. “And then you met Ba'al, who promised to deliver you Clones like you were used to.”

He nodded.

“As long as you fought for him.”

Another nod.

She shook her head. “He was stringing you along.”

“No! It would take time to solve all problems, but there was progress!”

That sounded more desperate than convinced.

“Even so, once he got it working, he'd replace you with Clones loyal to him.” Like Horde Prime had done.

“I was… prepared for that.”

“Prepared to out-plot a Goa’uld who has been around, plotting against his rivals, for thousands of years?” Catra snorted. “Do you even know how he ‘trained’ the human clones he brought here? The ‘test subjects’?”

“If we knew we could have done it ourselves!”

“He had them possessed by Goa'uld.” Adora had recovered from the revelation. “They were hosts.”

“But…” he shook his head. “We can't be possessed by Goa'uld. That wouldn't work.”

Adora slowly nodded. “He was either lying to you and hoping to use you until he could replace you with Jaffa and replicate your technology - or he was planning to create Clones he could possess.”

“Either way, you lose,” Catra added.

“No!” He shook his head. “No! That's… No!” He looked like he was about to cry.

Catra felt bad for a moment. Then she reminded herself that the Clone had tried to murder Adora.

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Former Ba’al’s Base, PT-9511, PT-9511 System, May 18th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“General, we've secured the perimeter of the base and have taken control of the mining sites on the planet. Thanks to the assistance of Queen Glimmer, we managed to prevent the Jaffa guards stationed there from holing up inside the mines.”

“Thank you, Colonel.” Jack O'Neill nodded in response. He was already aware of the facts, but a proper report was still needed.

“We've suffered light casualties, though before we could medevac the wounded to the hospital ship, Queen Glimmer had already taken them to the Supreme Commander for treatment.”

Meaning, Adora had healed them all. Well, Jack couldn't fault her for it, as long as she didn't strain herself too much. Which, despite the efforts of her friends, was still a potential danger. Adora needed to delegate more.

They had a hospital ship - well, a frigate with extended medical facilities, to be exact - with them for a reason. Sure, magic healing was great, but doctors could treat many wounds perfectly well.

“We've also started installing temporary barracks,” Colonel Maryland went on, “Until the temporary prisoner holding area is ready and we can move into the base's barracks.”

“Temporarily,” Jack added with a grin.

“Yes, sir.” Maryland smiled, but it was the humouring smile of a subordinate going along with a superior's joke, not a genuine one, Jack noted. The man obviously had no sense of humour. Even a German would have laughed.

“And with that in mind, has the Alliance made a decision about the fate of this base yet? I'd like to tell my troops whether or not they can plan long-term.”

“Nothing has been decided yet,” Jack replied. The Alliance Council hadn’t even scheduled a meeting to discuss this yet - which they wouldn't until Adora was back, anyway. The colonel knew or should know that as well, so this was probably just a more or less subtle reminder to keep him informed. “We won't forget you out here, Colonel, don't worry. You'll have a Burger King built next to the barracks in no time.”

Another forced laugh. Did anyone really take the rumours of garrisons being forgotten on foreign planets, leaving entire units stranded far away from Earth, seriously? Jack might have to look into this if that was common thinking. “If we're staying here, you can look forward to a Stargate being moved here, Colonel.” A shipyard needed a Stargate connection if only to move troubleshooters in on short notice. And most civilian contractors demanded significant compensation packages if they were employed on planets without the ability to use the Stargate to quickly return home in an emergency or just for a vacation.

Well, that wasn't Jack's problem. He just needed to oversee the base takeover until someone else was put in charge. Maryland seemed competent enough to handle base security, anyway, which was enough until the Alliance either sent someone to get the shipyards running for the Alliance or to dismantle them and move them to another planet that wasn't as close to Ba'al's territory.

“Is there anything else, Colonel?”

“No, sir.”

Jack sighed when the colonel left and checked his tablet. Catra had sent a few pictures of a mass of kneeling Clones. It seemed Adora’s visit to the captured Clones had gone as expected. They still would have to be vetted, but Jack didn't doubt that most of them would be serving in the Alliance, and on their old ships, soon enough.

He felt a bit bad about using Adora like that, but you couldn't be too choosy in war, and anything that turned enemies into allies was a godsend. Adora understood that as well, even if she complained from time to time.

Of course, Jack knew that this could, long-term, result in a mess, he knew from experience how working with religious fanatics was always a risk, but the alternatives were far worse. He'd rather deal with the Church of She-Ra than any other religion when it came to fanatics. At least Adora could be counted on to talk to her flock if there was a problem, and Jack could trust her not to abuse her power. Surely more than he could trust the preachers, priests, popes and whatever back home.

Besides, he had to worry about winning the war, not how to handle the peace afterwards. That was up to politicians, and Jack wasn't a politician.

A notice popped up on his tablet - Carter informing him that the clones, the human ones, were ready to be woken up and Jack would better head over so they could start. Well, she was far more professional about it, but that was the gist of it, so he started walking. It beats paperwork, anyway.

He reached the secure area where they had moved the clone container - Carter had flat-out rejected his suggestion to call it the Human Fridge - a few minutes later. The gang was already all there. Carter, Entrapta and Bow were bent over the consoles and gadgets, talking in tongues, and everyone else was watching and trying not to look lost.

He clapped his hands together. “So, ready for the great thawing?”

“Sir.” Carter frowned at him. “They're not frozen; they're in stasis.”

He grinned. “Sounds the same to me. So, how are you going to defrost them?”

She pressed her lips together, but he could see her lips twitching a little. “The process is automated. We simply have to start it and

the pods will do the rest.”

He looked at the various gadgets on the ground.

“We're closely monitoring the entire process, of course.” She sounded a little defensive, so Jack didn't press further.

“So, let's start? Or are we waiting for someone else?”

“No, sir.”

Carter had been right. It was a simple process. Also, a boring one - push a button and then wait. At least, it didn't take long until the pod opened with a soft hissing sound, which probably meant it was done.

“All vital signs are good,” Carter reported. “Neural activity detected, but we can't tell yet if that's just the basic activity of a newborn clone.”

The man’s eyes snapped open, and he looked around. Jack waved, and Adora stepped closer. “Hello! I'm She-Ra. You must be confused, I guess, but don't worry - we're here to help you.”

The man stared at her for several seconds, looking her over as if he was searching for something. “Do you serve Ba'al?” he finally asked.

“No, we don't serve Ba'al,” Adora told him. “We're…”

Before she could finish, the man snarled and attacked her with his bare fists.

Well, he tried. He tripped getting out of the pod, and Adora stopped his attempted tackle with one hand. “Please! We don't mean any harm!”

But the man wasn't listening. “Glory to Ba'al! Death to his enemies!” he screamed while flailing at her.

“Please stop! We’re not your enemy.”

“Glory to Ba'al! Death to his enemies! “Glory to Ba'al! Death to…””

A shot from a zat stunned him and put an end to the one-sided battle.

Jack sighed. “I guess that answers the question of whether Ba'al could produce loyal clones or not.”

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Ba’al’s Machinations Part 1

Earth Orbit, Solar System, May 19th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“We’ll do our best to welcome the lost fleet into our ranks, Your Divine Highness! We will also teach them how to think for themselves and make decisions about their own lives, of course - to prevent them from falling for the lies of the Goa’uld or anyone else.” Priest bowed deeply. “And I offer you the thanks of everyone in the fleet for saving them before it was too late.”

Adora suppressed a grimace. “We were too late and couldn’t save everyone,” she said. Like the clones that the Commander had had grown and mistaken for braindead out of ignorance. And Adora and her friends had personally killed several clones in the attack on Ba’al.

“If you couldn’t have saved them, no one could have, Your Divine Highness.” Priest smiled at her.

Well, that might be true for the Clones, but if Adora had been a bit more cautious, held back a bit, she might have saved the Commander’s guards - though she would have risked them hurting her friends, or worse. She could do better, though, and so she nodded without actually acknowledging the point.

“We’ve also been making some progress with the other fleets we have been reaching out to,” Priest went on. “Incidentally, the ability to create more of us has been a decisive factor for some of them - those who had resigned, thinking they would be the last of us. Knowing our people won’t disappear but have a bright future ahead of us has saved them.”

“That is good to hear, Priest,” Adora told him. She was quite aware that Priest’s people would also work on converting them to their faith, but if the alternative was to see entire fleets simply give up and wait to die… Adora didn’t like being worshipped -

who, except the Goa'uld, did? - but she would hate it if people died when they could have been saved.

"We live to follow your example, Your Divine Highness. Although we still need to find the rest of the Lost Fleet and save them from serving as Baal's unwitting puppets."

"Yes." They had not reacted to FTL-communication requests, and the ships sent to the known positions of the fleet had not found the - they had moved away. Now, there should be confusion after their Commander had been captured along with Ba'al, but Adora would have expected whoever was now in charge of the Lost Fleet to at least answer calls. "We're keeping up our efforts."

"After Ba'al's capture, his command structure should have been disrupted, causing friction or outright chaos in his forces," Priest commented. "Underlings fighting to take over or trying to carve out their own realm with whatever resources they can lay claim to. But we haven't found any evidence of that."

"We don't know the extent of his realm," Adora pointed out. "Only the bases the Commander was aware of." Which had been emptied and often razed to the ground before they arrived.

"We will find them, Your Divine Highness, and we will free all of Ba'al's slaves!"

Adora nodded again. They would indeed. Still, she had a bad feeling about this. Ba'al had been transferred to the Goa'uld holding facility on Earth and interrogation specialists were already talking to him, but the System Lord had, so far, proven completely uncooperative - and quite smug.

Something was up. Adora didn't know what, but she knew this.

And she was pretty sure that they had to find out what was going on, and as soon as possible, or the consequences would be grave. "How are the new trainees doing?"

"Oh, they are very motivated! We might have to slow down the training schedule to keep them from overworking themselves, but…"

Adora nodded as Priest started to detail the state of the new Clones training program. At least that was working as planned.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, May 19th, 2000

"...so we are in agreement. The Alliance will hold the base taken from Ba'al and keep the shipyards running while using the base to supply operations in the area."

Adora sighed under her breath as everyone sitting at the conference table nodded. It had taken too long for her taste, but the Command Council had finally agreed on a course of action.

"We'll need to move in reinforcements and fortify the base," she said.

"We already have a task force there to guard it," the American Secretary of Defense said.

"That won't be enough," she pointed out. "And the base's current security and fortifications aren't sufficient to protect it against infiltration attempts or large ground-based attacks. We also need a larger garrison and more infrastructure to supply the fleet."

"We can send one of the new units that have been raised to take over the garrison - it will allow them to keep working up while freeing the combat unit currently stationed there for other duties," his British colleague said.

"Two birds with one stone. Although we will need a Stargate that we can move there," the German minister added.

"We've contacted the Tok'ra to see if they know a Stargate that's not known to the Goa'uld so it can be moved there without them

noticing," Adora said. Of course, the Tok'ra also had asked to get some of the ships that would be built there. Which led to another decision they had to make. "Also, we need to decide if we convert the shipyard to build Alliance designs or keep producing Goa'uld ships," she said.

As Catra and Glimmer - and Sha're - had predicted, everyone agreed to convert them to produce alliance designs. But everyone disagreed about which designs should be built there and by whom.

Adora sighed, more audibly now. This would take a long while.

*****

Research base Alpha, First Moon of Enchantment, May 20th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"I have finished the analysis of the sample you brought."

Samantha Carter looked up from her computer screen upon hearing Loki's announcement. That had been faster than she had expected from him. And he wasn't complaining about the analysis having been a waste of time. "Thank you," she told him as she opened the file on her computer.

After a few seconds of skimming the data, she nodded. "So, it was a clone." All their efforts, and it *was* just a body double. Worse, now the real Ba'al would be warned and might change his plans. Unless the clone never knew his actual plans.

"Yes. Whoever did the work tried to hide the signs - they probably did use a sarcophagus in the attempt - but for a scientist like me, it was obvious."

For you when using Alpha's instruments. I'd like to see you do better in the field with only a portable computer, Sam thought with some annoyance. However… "Wouldn't the sarcophagus have rejuvenated the body?"

“In the default setting, yes. But even such a crude tool could be adapted and used more creatively.” Loki cocked his head in what was probably a shrug for the Asgard. “I assume they tampered with the radiation until it reversed some of its effects; the tissue showed signs of degradation that were similar to but incompatible with ageing effects.”

It was just a theory, but it seemed sound. And now Sam had another nightmare-inducing scenario to ponder: the threat of being aged in such a sarcophagus. Granted, compared to being possessed by a symbiont, it would be a mercy, and you could probably use a sarcophagus to undo such an effect, but to feel your body decay like that… She shuddered.

“I also analysed the samples from the human clones,” Loki went on.

“Ah?” Sam looked at him.

“I was looking for signs of what kind of research Ba’al might be doing on the Horde Clones.”

That explained his interest: Loki was hoping to find data he could use for his own project. “What did you find out?”

Loki’s mouth twitched in an Asgard frown. “The genetic code was left unchanged.”

“Ba’al doesn’t have to use genetic engineering on humans to get hosts,” Sam pointed out. Unlike Asgard, humans didn’t reject symbionts.

Loki frowned at her. “I had the hope that Ba’al would have used his test subjects more efficiently. But as was to be expected, the Goa’uld prefer to waste resources.”

Or they didn’t want to have others find out what they were doing by adding more secrets to clones planned to be expendable. But Loki was too focused on his own desires to consider this. “That’s the least of their sins,” Sam commented.

“Waste is one of the worst sins,” Loki, of course, had to disagree. “In any case, I request all the data you can gather from his research sites. It might prove useful for my task.”

“Of course.” Sam rolled her eyes, but Loki had already turned away. The arrogance of that scientist… Well, she had worked with worse on Earth, but it was still very annoying.

“Will we be duplicating this experiment?”

Sam didn’t jerk at Alpha’s sudden question. She wouldn’t give the bot the satisfaction. Instead, she slowly turned to look at the holoprojection. “There are currently no plans to clone humans,” she told them.

“Why not? Using an alien symbiont to implant pre-selected memories into clones is a very original way to make cloning more efficient. If we can duplicate the way memories are passed on, we could avoid having to spend so many resources on training new scientists up to an acceptable level to do more ground-breaking research, freeing up more resources for other projects.”

Sam narrowed her eyes. She knew very well that the only reason Alpha pretended to care about anything not directly related to the research done in this base was that the bot hoped to sway her into allowing her latest thoroughly unethical project. “That violates several fundamental principles of the Alliance.” Not that Alpha cared about that. “And it also would cause a very high single failure point. If the memories passed on were to develop faults - or were faulty to begin with - the consequences would be dire. The Asgard are the best example for a similar result.”

The holoprojection frowned but slowly nodded. “That is an argument I have not yet considered. I will now do so. Thank you.” Alpha faded from view.

“I’m surrounded by single-tracked minds,” Sam muttered under her breath - and made a mental note to check up on Beta’s research. The other First Ones bot running a research base

controlled by the Alliance had similar views on ethics and morality, namely that they were in the way of advancing science. And it fell to Sam to supervise both. Maybe she should…

Entrapta appearing in the door to Sam's office interrupted her thoughts. "Sam! Anise just called! She's coming over with her latest project! Oh, and she also has some data on Ba'al, I think."

That was good news - or so Sam hoped. After receiving confirmation that they had only captured a clone and dealing with both Loki and Alpha, Sam could use something uplifting. And Anise's latest project did sound intriguing.

*****

Bright Moon, Etheria, May 21st, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra stopped on the way through Bright Moon's market street. Another shop had opened up with products from Earth - or inspired by Earth products; she could tell with a glance that a lot of the merchandise were imitations. Ironically, in some cases because the quality was too good for the mass-produced wares common on Earth.

Acting on impulse, she entered the shop - maybe she'd find a gag gift for Adora or something to annoy Glimmer with. She ignored the display cases with bootlegged TV shows and movies she already knew or didn't want to know and skimmed the board games and other toys. Nothing interesting there, and the clothes seemed rather boring as well. Then again, she was used to the real thing, and once you learned to ignore the advertising that bombarded you everywhere on Earth, you soon stopped caring about most of the products as well.

Or, she added with a glance at the posters and framed pictures of various Earth actors and singers, about most of their stars. Especially those who just didn't get that they couldn't block the Stargates on both Earth and Etheria for hours to ship through a

small train of tour material including their personal mobile home… The Alliance was fighting a war and needed the gates.

Whatever, it didn't look like she'd find anything that caught her fancy here. Maybe she should…

“Look, it's here!”

That voice sounded familiar… Yes, she saw two Clones approaching the shop.

“Are you sure?”

“Yes! Look, there in the back!”

“In the back? That sounds disrespectful!”

Disrespectful? Catra frowned. What were they talking about? Oh! She grinned when she saw the two making a beeline for the toys in the back which prominently featured a local copy of an Earth-made ‘Sword of She-Ra’ toy.

“See? I told you we would find one!”

“Yes! Oh, and look - there's a set of figurines of Her Divine Highness as well!”

“That wasn't here yesterday! What a find!”

Catra watched as the two bought every scrap of She-Ra merchandise for frankly inflated prices, and again when the clerk replaced the stuff with more of the same from the back. The goat-man didn't quite meet her eyes while working, probably worried about her reaction.

She didn't yet know if he had a reason to worry, but she'd find out soon - it was almost time to head back to the Palace for dinner.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, May 21st, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...so things have been going well here in our absence. Mom's helping Dad run the kingdom."

"How is she doing?" Catra asked, cocking her head at Glimmer while she cut into her second serving of fried ice fish. She wasn't quite sure if Angella getting involved too deeply in the kingdom's politics was a good thing or not, but it was certainly important.

"Oh, she's doing…" Glimmer sighed. "...well."

Catra raised her eyebrows, then glanced at Bow, who looked amused instead of concerned. So, it wasn't anything serious but probably embarrassing. Not that he would tell.

"That's good!" Adora, of course, beamed.

"Yes." Glimmer bit a bit too forcefully in her bread roll, practically tearing a bite off with her teeth. Definitely embarrassing. And that was good. The last thing the Alliance needed was a power struggle between the two queens. Well, time to broach another topic.

"Did you know there's a significant market for She-Ra merchandise in the Horde?" Catra asked as casually as she could.

"What?" Adora stared at her.

"I saw two Clones buying every She-Ra toy in the market," Catra explained. "Overpriced or not."

"But I thought we… Oh, right. That's only Earth," Adora said. "We didn't make any agreements for Etheria."

"People are fleecing the Clones with She-Ra toys?" Glimmer asked. "In Bright Moon?"

“And probably elsewhere,” Catra added. “Looked like they have a good supply of the stuff.” She might ask Scorpia if she had any idea - it was one thing if the toys were made by hand, another if someone was using a factory.

“But… those are toys?” Adora shook her head. “Are they playing with them?”

“Many people collect toys,” Bow said. “It's a nice hobby.”

And you're one of them, Catra thought. Though he probably didn't collect She-Ra toys - he was already spending a lot on genuine Earth figurines and ‘simulation games’. “They probably put them up on their shrines,” she said.

And now Adora looked queasy.

“Do you want me to ban the sales?” Glimmer asked. “It's your, ah, likeness they're abusing. And they're exploiting the Clones.”

“No.” Adora shook her head. “No, that would be unfair.”

“You could start up a line of official merchandise,” Catra suggested. “Approved by you and with the profits going to charity or so.” The Clones in her church would probably consider the stuff blessed.

Adora stared at her. “I'm not going to profit from people who worship me! That would be… disgusting!”

“That's why you’d use the profits for charity,” Catra said. “If you don't do it, others will keep the profits for themselves.”

Adora pouted. “It's still wrong! I'd feel dirty doing that. Like ordering people to donate money - donations should be voluntary!”

She had a point, but it still meant others would profit from her followers. Maybe Catra should have a talk with Priest. If he wasn't already aware of it, he would like to know this.

“So… how are relations with the other kingdoms?” Adora asked in a transparent attempt to change the subject.

“Ah, nothing's much changed.” Glimmer shrugged. “Sweet Bee is still trying to get control of the Stargate, but her coalition is too divided to do anything.”

And too weak even if they were united. Especially during the war.

Catra nodded. It looked like things were well enough at home.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, May 22nd, 2000

“...and this, General O'Neill, is our prototype of the Composite Vision Enhancer and Protector System.”

Jack O'Neill could hear the ‘trademarked’ added to the name as the salesman - sure, his official title was ‘something-manager’, but he was here to sell something - gestured at a man dressed in bulkier combat fatigues including gloves and what looked like a standard Kevlar helmet with a diving mask and a gas mask attached. He made a noncommittal noise and circled the man while the salesman prattled on.

“As you can see…” The Salesman gestured to the model, who reached up, fiddled with the edges of the mask, and then pulled it off. “...it's based on modularity. You can detach the BC-protector for missions that do not need it and keep the Vision Enhancer, greatly improving the user's experience. The same goes for the gloves.”

The man stashed the gas mask - Jack wasn't going to call it a ‘BC-Protector’, trademarked - in a familiar-looking pouch at his belt and then pulled off the gloves and stuffed them in the same pouch.

“So, Mr Delgado… you basically added an NBC suit to the fatigues and a seal to the helmet?” Jack raised his eyebrows at the salesman.

The man didn’t even blush. “The suit including the boots and the helmet were designed from the ground up; you can't just add a protector system to the current fatigues or helmet.”

“Actually, you can,” Jack told him. “It's just that it comes as an outer suit you wear over your uniform. Like our old NBC suits.”

“But that would add more weight to a soldier and would take more time to put on in an emergency. With our system, they already wear the suit and sealed boots and can quickly protect themselves against attacks by biological or chemical agents without significantly reducing their effectiveness in the field. Not to mention that the integrated NV-goggles offer superior performance compared to the current technology.”

Jack doubted that - the suit did look a little cumbersome, probably barely any less restrictive than the old NBC suit he was used to. “Still looks like you just moved some parts around and called it a day.”

“We've been developing the system for some time, General. The recent submission request from the Alliance for an advanced combat uniform that included NBC protection was merely a coincidence. Unlike our competitor, we have a finished product.”

That was probably true. Jack doubted even a scummy company could have thrown together such a proposal in that time. Still… it looked a lot like the suits they already had. Since the Cold War, actually. Jack doubted that it offered enough of an upgrade to justify the cost of replacing the current gear. And it made you look like some overweight German soldier from World War I.

But it was the first proposal the Alliance had received, and Jack knew better than to dismiss it without testing it. “So, let's see how my troops do with it!”

“We're ready for a field test, General.” Delgado smiled.

*****

A few hours later, after the sales delegation had left and his soldiers were back at base cleaning up, Jack O'Neill was typing up his preliminary report. The suit had actually performed pretty decently. Better than he had expected. The seals had held up to testing, you could move around better than in the old suits - though you still felt the weight, and it got more than a little hot in the whole getup if you were out through your paces - and his troops had quickly gotten the hang of it, including the night-vision mask and the radio attachment. ‘Usability’, as Delgado had called it, had been improved indeed. The whole system, except for the stupid name, was a solid product that was a distinct improvement over the current NBC gear.

Unfortunately, that was all it was. Anyone could see that it had been developed before the arrival of the Etherians. It didn’t integrate magitech or advanced technology, it wasn't rated for space or low-atmosphere conditions - it wasn't rated for amphibian operations, either - and while it was laced with Kevlar, it didn't offer any better protection than the current vests, and if you added the optional ‘Hard Protector’, which was the new fancy name for a vest with ceramic plates, the weight increased considerably. And Jack had no doubt that if they managed to increase protection to the point the vest could withstand a staff blast, it would weigh even more.

No, in his honest opinion, the thing simply wasn't offering enough of an improvement over the current NBC suits the Alliance used. And compared to the Horde uniforms, it was clearly inferior.

And, while not official, Jack had asked Delgado about production capacity. It would take years to deliver enough of the suits to equip the US forces, much less the entire Alliance. Even just equipping Jack's special forces would take until the end of the year since the factories had yet to gear up for a production run. If they wanted it faster, the Alliance would have to build more

factories and license production. In short, they would be paying a fortune for a suit that would be obsolete when it reached the troops.

Too bad for Mr Delgado, but the Alliance wouldn’t buy his company's product. Jack added his conclusion to the end of the report, checked that the videos and pictures were attached properly, and sent the thing to Alliance Headquarters.

With that done, he could return to trying to figure out how to deal with Ba'al.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, May 23rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

“...and I was shocked, shocked beyond belief when I discovered how my brethren are treated on Earth. Raised to be enslaved and abused their entire lives, then slaughtered to feed dogs when they are too old to work! How can you people allow this crime? Even worse, some humans eat horses! That's cannibalism! I must…”

Adora turned the tablet off and sighed. Swift Wind's interview on Earth had caused quite a few issues. Well, his interview paired with a report about horse slaughterhouses… Who had thought that it was a good idea to allow that?

Right, freedom of the press, she reminded herself. Earth people could be so stupid at times! Well, they had to deal with the mess now. Adora wasn’t going to tell a bunch of mostly girls that eating horses was fine and not cannibalism, or that using horses for anything but riding them wasn't slavery. That was their problem, not hers.

“And if they continue to bother me with their requests, I'm going to give an interview and tell them that it *is* cannibalism and slavery!” she muttered as she lay back on the bed.

“Hm?” Catra stepped out of the bathroom with a towel on her head… and nothing else.

“Adora?”

“What? Sorry!” Adora blurted out, blushing a little. And a bit more at Catra's smirk. “Just venting about the horse issue.”

“You mean the Crusade Against Cannibalism?” Catra sat down on the bed and stretched.

“They're really calling it that?”

“Brown said something about ‘alliteration gone wrong’, but apparently, PETA is known for such stuff and was pretty effective.” Catra shrugged. “He also said that the ‘agro lobby’ was being idiots for trying to counter it with the claim that it isn't cannibalism if it is a different species was making things worse for them instead of better even though it was technically correct.” She snorted.

Adora frowned. “You talked to Mister Brown about that?”

Catra gave her a look. “I had to know how bad it was before the Alliance drags you into this mess.”

Ah. Adora smiled at that. “Thank you.”

“Someone has to shield you from trying to solve every problem,” Catra replied with a snort. “Anyway, it's not our problem. We don't eat horses in Bright Moon. And we don't use them to pull wagons or ploughs either.”

Well, Adora remembered Micah commenting about the costs of sheltering much of Etheria's horse population, but it hadn't seemed to be a real problem either. And it wasn't her problem.

Though without She-Ra, Swift Wind wouldn't exist, she reminded herself. In a way, she had caused all of this… “Ow!” She jerked

and glared at Catra, who was slowly retracting the claw that had been poking Adora's calf.

“You were blaming yourself for this,” Catra told her with a frown.

“I…” Adora sighed, and Catra snorted again.

“It’s not your fault, you idiot.”

Adora sighed. Catra meant well, but… Hm. Maybe this was the time to address it. “You know, you don't have to keep blaming yourself, either.”

Catra tensed. “I'm not blaming myself for things that weren't my fault,” she said, turning her head away.

Adora sighed once more. “Not everything you did was, well…”

“I had a choice!” Catra snapped. “I know what I did. And why.”

“And you changed,” Adora replied.

Catra didn't answer and hugged herself, pulling her knees to her chest.

Adora wanted to reach out and hug her, but… her lover was still too tense. “You changed to do the right thing,” she said instead. Damn, that sounded stupid!

“It doesn't make up for what I did wrong.”

“That's not how it works,” Adora objected.

“You have to right what you did wrong. That's how it works.” Catra turned her head slightly to look at her from the corners of her eye. “And I broke too much to fix it.”

“That's not how it works! It's not some…” Adora shook her head. “If you do something nice for someone, it’s not OK to hurt them afterwards, is it?”

Catra blinked. “That's… what?”

Adora bit her lower lip, feeling her cheeks heat up a little. She hadn't really thought this through. She shouldn't have started this without being prepared. But she couldn’t stop now. “It's not a question of… balancing things. It's about *changing* so you aren't the person who did all this any more.” She stopped herself before she said ‘growing up’.

“That doesn't help the people I hurt.”

“Someone told me we can't help everyone,” Adora said.

“But we should help those we hurt,” Catra shot back.

“We are. We're fighting the Goa'uld to protect everyone,” Adora pointed out. “And we saved everyone when we stopped the Heart of Etheria. We are helping,” she repeated herself.

“It's not the same,” Catra protested.

This time, Adora reached out and pulled Catra into a hug. Her lover squirmed some, still tense, but didn't really resist. And Adora could feel her relax a little once she was in her lap. “You aren't the same either. Not any more.”

Catra sighed deeply - Adora could feel her shiver, could feel her muscles tense and relax again - but didn't object.

Adora counted that as a win.

After a moment, Catra said: “That doesn't mean you can keep blaming yourself for everything.”

Adora snorted softly and hugged her more tightly.

*****

Royal Palace, Dryl, Etheria, May 24th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“So, this is my home. Kinda - I don't really spend that much time here, actually - well, not the majority of my time, if you tally everything. I'm still here a lot of time, relatively. It's just that the Spacelab is more modern, and Alpha has more First Ones technology and that fascinating data bank, and you said we need to keep an eye on Loki, and I can't neglect Darla or she'll think I don't like her any more, and every time I'm here I need to deal with the ruling things… But! The kitchen here makes the best tiny food! And I have all my first bots here! Well, those that survived that tiny little First Ones virus accident.”

Samantha Carter nodded as she looked around. She had been here before, but not very often, though nothing seemed to have changed.

Anise, though, was visiting for the first time. And she seemed a little apprehensive. “Virus accident?”

“Oh, don't worry - it was a computer virus that made all my bots - well, all with First Ones technology, which were all of them - attack me and my friends. Perfectly harmless for people. Except for if you're a First One, I guess, though that was just the one time.”

Anise nodded. She was taking Entrapta's explanation better than Sam had, back when she had first visited. She didn't seem to question the safety of the lab here, what with what looked like two dozen bots in various states of repair lining the walls, and more parts stacked on shelves.

Hordak, on the other hand, had ignored the whole discussion and gone straight to one of the consoles at the wall, next to the fabber.

“So… let's do *science*!” Entrapta beamed.

Sam nodded. The Alliance had to deal with Ba'al before he could create an army of loyal and skilled clones, but there was nothing Sam and her friends could do about that at the moment; they

were waiting for the spy bot network and the interrogation of Ba'al's clone to get results. So, they were free to use their time to pursue other projects. Such as Anise's proposal.

“You brought the prototypes?” Entrapta asked, craning her neck to look at the bag Anise carried with her.

“They're not exactly prototypes. I didn't design them - I found them.”

“But they could be prototypes, just made by someone else!”

Anise blinked, then nodded. “I don’t know enough to disprove that theory.” She reached into the bag and pulled out several devices.

Sam took a closer look while Entrapta reached out with her hair and grabbed one. They were roughly shaped like cylinders, a bit too large to easily fit Sam's palm, with several buttons and a large crystal set into one end. If the General were here, he'd joke about lightsabers. They did look a little bit like… She frowned. They looked familiar.

“We recovered them from a fallen civilisation. We don't know if they were designed as tools or weapons,” Anise explained, “but they allow you to manipulate gravity. Let me demonstrate.”

She grabbed one of the cylinders and pushed a button, causing the crystal to light up. Then she pointed it at one of the bots in a corner and pressed another button. A moment later, the bot began to float. And so did the tools next to it.

“You can reduce or increase gravity in its area of effect. You narrow or widen the area of effect, but that affects the strength of the field,” Anise went on, showing the controls.

“Oh! It's much more compact than our own technology!” Entrapta beamed. “If we can adapt that, we could enhance all our vehicles!”

“We haven't been able to decipher the technology,” Anise said with a frown. “We do know it's powered by magic; the device doesn't work unless it's on a planet where magic has been restored.”

“Oh! It’s a magic device?” Entrapta beamed. “That would explain its size!” Then she frowned. “But that would also mean we can't use it in space… Unless we adapt it to magitech!”

“That was what we were hoping for,” Anise said with a smile.

Sam blinked. She had seen some of those symbols before… “The cube!” she blurted out.

“The cube?” Anise frowned.

“Oh, the cube!” Entrapta gasped. “You're right!”

“The cube?” Anise repeated herself.

“Yes. The design elements do match some of the cube's,” Hordak agreed.

“We found an alien data cube some time ago,” Sam said. “Our attempts to decipher it haven't been successful.”

“Well, we haven't really focused on it - there was so much else to do,” Entrapta added. “But! If you found those devices in the ruins of their makers, we could probably find more clues about their civilisation to help with that!”

Sam nodded. If they had more examples of the unknown aliens’ technology to study, they should be able to crack the encryption.

“I see.” Anise nodded. “Unfortunately, we recovered the devices from a Goa'uld's vault. There were no clues about their origin.”

“And the Goa'uld?” Hordak asked.

“Dead.” Anise sounded slightly sorry.

“Well… maybe we can find out more through analysing the devices,” Entrapta said.

Sam nodded, though she wasn't very hopeful.

“And we can work on that armour project,” Hordak added.

Right. The other reason they visited Entrapta's palace.

*****

Above the Atlantic, Earth, May 25th, 2000

“...and asked to comment on the fact that several Senators have proposed bills to enshrine the use of horses on farms and for other purposes as part of America's cultural heritage, Swift Wind stated that he wouldn't expect anything else from people who celebrated human slavery as their cultural heritage but expressed his hope that the rest of America would have moved past that dark time of their country’s history…”

Sitting in a window seat on the shuttle to Greenland, Catra snorted at the outrage Swift Wind's statement had caused in the United States. “Gotta hand it to him; he did his homework.”

“...although he also rebuked the claim from a PETA spokesperson that animals who could not live in the wild should be euthanised, stating that ‘murdering those who have been forced to depend on you is even worse than forcing them to depend on you in the first place’, and firmly denied that he supported PETA's proposal to cull most livestock animals, so...”

Catra shook her head. Whenever she thought Earth's people couldn't surprise her any more, they went and did something she wouldn't have thought possible.

“Meanwhile, the French Parliament is still debating whether or not horse meat should be considered part of the cultural and gastronomical heritage of France. While some representatives from rural areas supported the notion and planned to add more

controversial food to a proposed law, others denied that horse meat was a traditional French dish and decried it as a stereotype…"

"Do you have to watch that?"

Catra looked up from her tablet and grinned at Adora. "We have to keep informed of Earth's political movements."

"It's not a political movement!" her lover insisted. "It's just a… Jack called it a 'flash in a pan'."

Catra made a sceptical noise. "Have you seen the clips of little girls protesting against the 'enslavement and eating of horses'? How many Earth politicians do you think will jump at the chance to get their support?"

Adora frowned at her. "I got a ton of letters asking me to 'smite the bad horse murderers'."

"You're their champion - you ride Swift Wind." Catra shrugged. "At least it has drowned out the 'Clones have no souls' campaign the religious fanatics launched."

Adora didn't look happy about that. Catra cocked her head to the side and looked at her.

Her lover sighed. "Priest is already looking for a planet to settle 'homeless horses' on, and for bot designs to take care of them. Because that supposedly is 'the least we can do for the sacred steed' of She-Ra."

Catra chuckled at that - until she remembered how many horses were on Earth, and how much such a move would strain the Alliance's logistics. "Let's hope he's waiting with that until after the war."

Adora nodded.

Catra went back to skimming the news on her tablet. They would soon arrive at Thule base.

*****

Thule Air Force Base, Greenland, Earth, May 25th, 2000

"...and all our specialists agree that this Ba'al honestly believes that he is the original Ba'al and not a clone," Major Bradbeck explained.

Catra frowned. "He tried to kill himself." She didn't think Ba'al would do that.

"We think that this was the result of a mental conditioning he was subjected to, to ensure he wouldn't be caught - or to ensure he would not attempt to usurp the original. However, that is mere speculation; even with the new intel from the Tok'ra, we have not been able to confirm that. It would also be possible that Ba'al, the original, given his age, is or was slightly delusional, and that was passed on to his clones," Bradbeck went on.

"Delusional?" Adora asked.

"None of the other Goa'uld prisoners have attempted suicide," Bradbeck replied. "Ba'al's clone might honestly believe that by killing himself, he will return somehow. Or that might be part of the suspected mental conditioning. Even after his poison glands were surgically removed, we had to place him on a suicide watch to keep him from attempting to end his life in his habitat by other means."

Catra pressed her lips together. She was far too familiar with that kind of mental conditioning. She had almost succeeded, too. If not for Adora… She felt a hand close around hers and squeeze, and glanced to her side.

Adora smiled gently at her, Catra nodded, taking a deep breath.

“What can we do about that?” Adora asked. “We can't let him kill himself because he's forced to by Ba'al.”

Bradbeck grimaced for a moment. “We've started therapy for him, but…” He spread his hands as if it was his fault. “...none of our psychologists and psychiatrists has much if any experience with Goa'uld patients.”

“And you've been focusing on gaining actionable intel,” Catra added.

“Yes. Our orders made finding out where Ba'al and his bases are a priority.”

“Did you have any success so far?” Adora asked.

“We think we're making progress, but as I said, so far, we have not gained any confirmed intel. We have several theories based on a few comments of his that need to be investigated, and we hope the Tok’ra’s efforts will bear fruit in that area, but the special conditions under which we operate - the lack of direct contact, the fact he’s an alien and has to use a keyboard to communicate - make it a challenge to gain any intel from the subject.”

Catra was aware of that. And she didn't expect much, anyway. Not at this point. Not until they could break down whatever mind control Ba'al had used on the clone.

“We'll bring in more people to work on this. People familiar with similar cases,” Adora said. “Can we see him now?”

“Ah, yes, of course. But I have to warn you - he's very uncooperative.”

“We know,” Adora said, and Catra chuckled despite the situation. That was putting it mildly.

*****

Ba’al’s Machinations Part 2

Colorado Springs, Colorado, United States of America, Earth, May 27th, 2000

“Come in!” Jack O’Neill yelled when he heard the doorbell ring. “We’re in the backyard.”

“We know,” Sha’re told him as she stepped on the porch. “We saw it on the approach.” She nodded at him, then at Teal’c. “Hello!”

Teal’c nodded back at her and then returned to watching the grill as if he expected it to attack him.

“I figured that was you,” Jack replied. She had passed the test and was now qualified to pilot shuttles, after all - Daniel had told him. In detail.

“Oh?” She frowned. “Did I mess up the landing?”

“Not exactly. But none of the security teams coming in fly over my yard, and Carter always takes the straight approach,” Jack explained as he shifted some of the plates with steaks and sausages around on the table after checking the spices.

“Hi, Teal’c! You did fine, honey,” Daniel said as he joined them. “I dropped the drinks off on the table, and the potato salad is in the fridge.”

“Daniel! You’ve got it backwards!” Jack shook his head with a snort. “The beer goes in the fridge!” He blinked. “Unless you brought it in the new coolers we got.”

“We don’t have one of those coolers,” Daniel said.

“We’re not in the Special Forces,” Sha’re added as she sat in one of the chairs on the lawn. “So we don’t have access to one.”

"And we wouldn't steal military medical equipment to transport beer even if we were." Daniel frowned at both of them.

Jack faked a gasp. "Steal? I'm testing them! Can't trust the lives of my troops to something that might break down in the field, can I?" Besides, if he wanted a portable high-tech cooler for his beer, he'd just ask Entrapta. OK, he'd probably get a fridge-bot that could float or something if he did it, but he'd get it. Carter would frown at him for it, of course, but mostly because she hadn't thought of it.

"Hm." Actually, a floating bot to dispense cool drinks and stuff in the field would be a neat thing. Like one of those Ice Cream Barges the Navy pukes used to have, just sized for a company or platoon. It could double as an emergency stretcher, too. And maybe make it heat up meals as well. On the other hand, all the power needed for the thing would probably make hiding from the enemy a lot harder unless it could use a stealth generator…

"Jack?" Sha're frowned at him.

Daniel sighed. "I don't know what he's thinking, but it can't be good."

"Daniel!" Jack pouted. "I was merely going over a potential addition to the Alliance arsenal in my head."

"Didn't you tell everyone that there wouldn't be any talk about the war this evening? If Sam hears that…"

Jack frowned at him. That was hitting below the belt! "It was just an idle thought," he said. "And don't you dare tell Carter, or she'll be behind her laptop all evening, doing some remote work on Etheria!"

"I think the communication lag makes that inefficient," Teal'c commented.

"I'm sure she can think of something she can do," Jack replied. Carter had mentioned once that it was actually possible to work

remotely across the distance, but frustrating since you had to wait so long for everything, and some fine manipulations were impossible. “But not today! Today is for relaxing. Just us!” SG-1 (and Sha’re, since she was kind of an honourary member by now). He hadn’t invited the Etherians, but they were busy doing princessly or politician-ly things anyway, what with all the talk about horses’ rights. If he didn’t know any better, he’d thought that this was all a ploy to distract the idiots in Congress and in the media from the Clones rights issue. It was working, anyway - the news was full of people screaming about tradition or horse murder, not idiots talking about whether or not Clones had souls or were the devil’s tools or whatever.

“And speaking of… She’s late.” He checked his watch with a frown. Should he call her to check that she hadn’t forgotten the time while working on another alien problem?

“It’s just been five minutes,” Daniel said.

“It’s Carter,” Jack said. “You know how punctual she is. If she…” He trailed off and cocked his head to the side. That sounded like…

“I believe that that is her shuttle,” Teal’c spoke up.

“Yeah.” At least, Jack hoped so.

The shuttle did take the optimal route to the landing pad, set down, and lifted off a minute later — just enough time to drop off a passenger.

And half a minute later, the doorbell rang again.

“Come in, Carter!” Jack yelled, smiling. “We’re about to start! If you have food, drop it off in the kitchen, if you have drinks, drop them in the fridge, if you brought work, in the trash it goes!”

“I didn’t bring any work, sir,” Carter said with a slight frown as she stepped on the lawn a little later. “Hello, Daniel, Sha’re, Teal’c.”

“Sam! How are you doing?” Daniel smiled at her.

"No talk about work!" Jack cut in at once. "I've spent the whole week discussing plans to deal with Ba'al before he builds up a clone army and fleet, I don't want to spend my weekend doing the same!" Not when they all had to wait until their recon ships, spy bots and Tok'ra operatives had still to find Ba'als other hidden bases before they could actually do anything but waste time on hypotheticals."

Carter frowned at him again, but there was something… was she smirking? "Alright, so I won't bore you all with talks about our latest project, new armoured uniforms and exoskeletons for the Alliance."

She was definitely smirking when she grabbed a bottle of beer and took a seat.

And now Jack couldn't ask for the inside information about the new armour Carter and Entrapta were building without looking like a hypocrite! He frowned at her, then at his grinning friends. Even Teal'c was smiling - kind of.

Grumbling, he grabbed the first two steaks to put them on the grill.

*****

Etheria System, May 29th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...and this is Her Divine Highness, She-Ra, Princess of Power and Supreme Commander of the Alliance against the Goa'uld!"

As Adora forced herself to smile and stepped forward, the Clones assembled in the hangar of the future flagship of the Fourth Fleet cheered loudly.

This isn't as bad as I feared, she thought as she approached the lectern at the edge of the stage. They're just cheering. That's normal.

As if someone had read her thoughts, the first row started to bow, followed by the other rows. It almost felt orchestrated - she couldn't tell who amongst the Clones was a veteran from Third Fleet now serving as cadre in the Fourth Fleet and who was a fresh recruit from the Lost Fleet of (formerly) Ba'al's forces - and she shot a glance at Priest, who had announced her, but the Clone's expression was as polite as ever. Which probably meant he had planned this - hadn't he asked Jack about fan choreographies or something recently?

Well, this wasn't the time to ask further questions. She stifled her sigh and addressed the assembled Clones: "Please, stand."

They straightened at once and changed to parade rest. If Catra were here - her lover had taken a detour to Alpha - she would comment about how sharp the formation looked, followed by some remark about how no unit ready for inspection was ready for combat.

"I am happy to see so many of you here, willing to not only leave your past behind you but to fight for your and everyone's future," she began. "The Alliance doesn't fight to conquer but to liberate. Not to destroy our enemies but to protect those in need. Not for revenge but for justice. Not with malice but with mercy. Those of you who were part of the Lost Fleet, those of you who fought the Alliance, we welcome you in our ranks, and we do not condemn you for your past."

She let her gaze sweep over the ranks, trying to impress on everyone how serious she was.

"All of us here - including me - once fought for Horde Prime." Indirectly, as she had served Hordak and Horde Prime hadn't even known what Hordak was doing on Etheria, and technically, she hadn't actually fought in the Horde war before she deserted, but she had been raised in the Horde, just like the Clones had. "And all of us realised how wrong that was." Some sooner than others, of course. But Adora wouldn't judge. "We realised this despite being manipulated from birth, raised in ignorance of the truth and

indoctrinated to obey blindly and not question orders and rules - and learned to make up excuses for anything that didn't fit and to ignore that for which there were no excuses."

If she were speaking to Alliance soldiers on Etheria or Earth, there would be a reaction by now. For good or ill, people would whisper and shout and make themselves known.

Not the Clones. They stood in silence, at attention, listening intently.

Adora suppressed a wince and raised her chin. "All of us here are willing to fight to save others from the same fate. To free those who are held in slavery, in chains both literal as well as made from ignorance and lies, ruled by and worshipping false gods. This is what the Alliance stands for: The right of every sapient being to be free to decide their own fate. This is what we are fighting for - and this is why we fight the Goa'uld.

"They not only deceive people into worshipping them and brutally oppress everyone they can, they also possess people, dooming their hosts to become prisoners in their own bodies. They remove even the least shred of power, the least shred of dignity their victims have, all in the name of gathering more power and more control over everyone else.

"And they have done so for thousands of years, unchallenged and undefeated, spreading untold pain and misery across the galaxy.

"Until the Alliance. Until we decided to fight them. To save their victims. And to ensure they cannot oppress anyone ever again. That is why we - all of us, you and me - are here. We'll be fighting for everyone, and we will win!"

For a moment, silence reigned after she finished. Then the first Clone started to cheer, and a moment later, the entire hangar full of people was screaming and yelling.

Adora smiled. This was why she was serving as the Supreme Commander of the Alliance - to lead and inspire those who fought

the good fight.

Then the chanting started. “She-Ra! She-Ra! She-Ra!”

That wasn’t too bad, either. The Princess Alliance had chanted her name on occasion as well.

But then the Clones started bowing again.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, May 30th, 2000

“...and this is the Improved Combat Armour Mark III! It is vacuum-rated, which means it also resists chemical and biological weapons, well, most of them - Alpha mentioned some First Ones prototypes of biological weapons that might eat through the armour, though you can argue that those are actually a physical attack just on the nano-scale, so while the effect is similar to acid, which would be a chemical attack, I think we still meet all the requirements the Alliance demanded.”

Samantha Carter nodded when the General looked at her after Entrapta's short speech. “Technically, the nano-plague Alpha mentioned could be seen as a biological attack since the nanites are based on living organisms, yet the attack vector uses physical force, but the side effects include a fog made up from the disassembled material, which is often but not always toxic, especially when inhaled. Albeit if that were to be ruled a chemical attack, then any attack that sets a target on fire would have to be classified in a similar way since burning vehicles often release toxic fumes,” she added.

The General stared at her. “I wasn't concerned with the legalities. I wanted to know if we actually have that stuff.”

“No, sir. The samples were destroyed on the Supreme Commander’s orders,” Sam replied.

“But we could make a new batch if you wanted,” Entrapta unhelpfully added. “We kept all the data in case someone else re-invents it and we need to counter it.”

“That's very reassuring,” the General commented with a grimace.

Entrapta completely missed his sarcasm and nodded with a beaming smile. “I know, right? Imagine deleting all the data!”

Sam cleared her throat and gestured at the soldier wearing the armour. “As you can see, this is just the armoured suit; we are still working on the armoured exoskeleton.” She wasn't going to call it ‘power armour’. Not after a quick internet search.

“It looks like a Horde uniform with the evil symbols filed off,” the General said.

Sam frowned at that. That was factually incorrect in more than one sense. “This is a new design, sir. But as form follows function, similarities to existing designs could not be avoided.”

“And that's a good thing!” Entrapta chimed in. “We think we can retool some of the factories in the Scorpion Kingdom to produce the suits. Or re-retool, in a sense, since those factories used to produce Horde uniforms.”

Sam met the raised eyebrows and slight smirk of the General without flinching and continued: “It's composed of an insulated undersuit on top of which the armour plates and a sealant gel that resists kinetic and thermal energy are added.”

“That sounds like you glued the plates on the suit.”

“In a very simplified manner, that is correct,” Sam said, smiling at the General's surprise. The gel was, after all, the real heart of the design. The undersuit was known technology, just a slightly tweaked version of Entrapta's spacesuit design, and the rigid armour plates were only advanced technology since they used the same material as Horde ships and vehicles. But the sealant was the key. Not only did it hold the plates in place and provided an

additional layer of armour underneath them, reducing spalling and protecting the insulated undersuit, but it also absorbed both kinetic and thermal energy and served as flexible armour over the joints and other moving parts of the suit. “The sealant coating can resist a staff weapon blast, and the plates will repel multiple impacts.”

“What about zats?” the General asked.

“An uncompromised armour will resist two shots from a zat'nik'tel. A third in rapid succession will render the armour non-functional, though the wearer should still survive it.”

“Non-functional?”

“Mostly disintegrated, sir.”

“I see. And how heavy is that stuff?”

“The weight depends on the size, but it is comparable to the full interceptor multi-threat body armour system used by the US Army,” Sam replied.

“That means it's heavier than that stuff,” the General said.

“The weight is better distributed,” Sam pointed out. “And it provides much-improved mobility.”

“Well, let's put that to the test, shall we?” He grinned.

“The helmet is fully sealed, with enhanced vision and a HUD display and offers both an air and liquid filter system and an autonomous air supply with carbon-dioxide scrubbers and an integrated communication system that can be upgraded to include FTL range, though this will require an additional repeater module to be carried by at least one person in the unit,” Sam finished. She had prepared for the presentation, and she wouldn't let the General cut it short.

“And it can link up with other systems and sensors, providing you a complete picture based on all the data we have - everyone will know everything!” Entrapta beamed. “You can see through walls as long as one sensor in the network covers the area behind the wall, but that might cause a bit of disorientation - you need to be careful not to run into the walls if you use it.”

“Alright. Sounds funky. Let’s see how it holds up in the field!”

Sam nodded at the soldier serving as a mannequin, and he walked over to the other test pilots waiting at the edge of the assault course.

The General addressed the soldiers. “It's a live fire exercise. Make sure you're only shooting the bots. We don't want to test the armour the hard way.”

“Oh, unless you're using armour-piercing rounds, the armour should hold up,” Entrapta said. “We extensively tested it against small arms. Though if the rounds hit a non-rigid spot, it might still hurt.”

The General frowned at her, then glared at his soldiers. “That doesn't mean you can get sloppy. I'll be watching the entire run and I'll rate it as an exercise. Don't disappoint me!”

The four soldiers nodded and grabbed their weapons, then started the test. Sam didn't think they were slowed down by the armour, but she wasn't as familiar with the Special Forces as the General, and he was watching in silence.

It wasn't until they finished that he nodded. “Decent time. We'll have to do a few more runs, but it looks like you've got a solid design there.”

“We need more testing,” Sam pointed out - these were prototypes, rushed to get into testing - but she agreed with his assessment. However, it would take some more time to get the design approved for production. Unfortunately, the work on the armoured exoskeleton was not nearly as advanced; they had only

started on that while the armoured suits had been a side project for some time. And the exoskeleton would take much longer to get into production afterwards - if it was approved in the first place.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, June 5th, 2000

"...and Ba'al's clone has tried twice more to commit suicide in the same manner despite the fact he must have realised that this would not work. Our analysts agree that he is becoming more unstable the longer he cannot obey the - implanted or imprinted - urge to kill himself, leading to a complete mental breakdown. Depending on the results, this might provide an opportunity to gain his cooperation."

Catra winced at the report from the intelligence officer. Not because she felt pity for the cloned snake since she could empathise with his mental state and he wasn't really to blame for it - Ba'al must have cloned him for this fate. No, it was the intel officer's hopeful tone at using that to break the prisoner that made her cringe. That wouldn't go over well with Adora.

"Colonel Lenny!" Adora snapped. "The Alliance does not let prisoners suffer mental breakdowns to interrogate them! We're better than this!"

To his credit, the Colonel didn't falter much under her glare. "Supreme Commander, we're trying all we can to help the prisoner, but the mental conditioning has proven to be too strong for our attempts so far - Ba'al's clone is resisting our efforts. We can only hope that once his mental state degrades further, this will change and allow us to help him."

Catra had heard excuses from soldiers for messing up before, and she wasn't convinced that the Colonel actually gave a damn about the prisoner, but Adora slowly nodded, seemingly mollified. Well, it

wasn't as if they could do anything else - even She-Ra's magic couldn't heal whatever had been done to the clone's mind.

“So, basically, Ba'al's clone hasn't provided us with any actionable intel so far?” General Naird didn't sound like he was asking more than rhetorically.

“That's not entirely correct, sir,” the Colonel replied. “He did boast about his future revenge, and how he will return, and has been getting more detailed in his threats as his attempts to suicide remain unsuccessful. This has resulted in several leads we can pursue with the help of the Tok'ra. We assume, based on some of his rants, that he's not focusing on building Horde frigates and other warships but planning to build shipyards, both mobile Horde fleet train units and planet-based shipyards such as the one we captured, while he perfects his cloning technology so he can then surge his enemies with rapidly expanding numbers of ships and crews.”

Catra pressed her lips together. That meant that they had a shrinking window of opportunity to stop Ba'al without taking huge casualties in the process. She'd have preferred it if Ba'al had taken less of a gamble and gone for more warships from the start.

Naird, though, looked positively surprised. “So, we just have to nip his build-up in the bud before it reaches critical mass?”

“Effectively, yes, sir,” the Colonel replied in a tone that clearly said that things weren’t so simple.

Naird nodded. “Good. All that remains is finding his shipyards then. And taking them from him like we took his first base.”

“We have to find them first, General,” Adora pointed out. “And while the Tok'ra are focusing on this, and we're launching as many recon missions as we can, we have yet to find one of Ba'al's other bases.”

Catra nodded. The bastard had taken a page out of Horde Prime's books and kept his forces compartmentalised. None of the Clones

from the Lost Ships knew where the other parts of Ba'al's forces were. The captured Jaffa, those who had converted, had been a bit more helpful, but they only knew some planets under Ba'al's control, and none of those had any shipyards.

"And we'll have not only to staff the shipyards but also man the ships they produce," Admiral Biggs said. "That will take time."

Admiral Brown-Emerson shook his head. "If the most recently captured base is any indication, then we can expect the majority of the workers to convert to our side thanks to your efforts, Supreme Commander." He smiled at Adora.

And of Priest, Catra mentally added. "We cannot count on that for the future," she said. "We know that Ba'al is already cloning workers who are far more fanatical in following him." The ones they had found in the base had not shown any signs of defecting to the Alliance - or converting to the Church of She-Ra.

"But those clones have yet to observe the Supreme Commander's personal power," the admiral objected. "We know that such displays have shaken the faith of fanatical Jaffa warriors in the past - and of Horde Clones who were imprinted to obey Horde Prime unto death."

Adora shifted on her seat, Catra noticed. "That happened after I removed Horde Prime, not before," her lover said. "We can't count on that."

"And we shouldn't be using a made-up religion to convert the slaves of the Goa'uld," Admiral Biggs added. "They worshipped fake gods all their lives; they deserve better."

Adora blinked before she frowned. "Believe me, I don't like being worshipped, but that's a choice people made and I won't deny them their freedom of religion."

"But it's a made-up religion! Even you agree with that - and you are their idol!" Biggs protested.

“All religions are made up,” Catra cut in, flashing her teeth at the man. “Yours isn't any better.”

“Catra!” Adora hissed.

“I don’t think this is the place for that discussion,” General Steiner said. “Nor should the Alliance judge any religion's worth.”

“Except for the Goa'uld’s,” General Naird added. “They are fake gods fooling their worshippers with lies and tricks.”

“We don't prohibit people from worshipping the Goa'uld either,” Adora said. “Freedom of religion applies to every religion.”

The other members of the Command Council nodded at that, but Catra saw that Biggs and a few others did so rather reluctantly. Though, she suspected, for different reasons.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, June 6th, 2000

“...and in other news, Senator Smith has proposed a bill that would criminalise the production, importing and consumption of horse meat in the United States. When asked to comment on the fact that in many states, the slaughter of horses for human consumption was already illegal, he stated that this was another reason to ban the practice. Several agricultural experts pointed out that the United States exported significant amounts of horse meat, and that this would affect…”

Jack O'Neill switched channels. It might be un-American, but he was fed up with hearing about horses, flying or not. As if the world didn't have bigger problems! Hell, he'd even had to crack down on a discussion that got a bit out of hand among his soldiers over the damn thing!

“...allegations that the famous singer's relationship with the sorceress was merely an attempt to be able to tour Etheria despite the current restriction on civilian travel through Stargates -

a restriction that has been challenged in court - were denied by her management, though anonymous sources…"

Jack switched channels again. He wasn't in the mood for celebrity gossip, either.

"...the Vatican has denied that the Pope has received the unofficial leader of the Church of She-Ra, the Horde Clone named 'Priest', for a private meeting and its speaker refused to comment on the Holy See's stance toward the rapidly growing new religion, or whether or not this was related to rumours about religious persecution of several religions including both Christian sects and the Church of She-Ra in China, though…"

Jack clenched his teeth and pushed the remote's button again. He definitely didn't want to hear about religious issues; he had to tell off several of his 'colleagues' who wanted to talk about why the people on the liberated planets weren't converting to Christianity instead of 'pagan cults' and what could be done to change that. "Maybe those idiots should consider the fact that bringing a book when the competition brings a miracle-working Princess who personally freed your planet doesn't work out too well?" he muttered. Better not, he thought - they might try to limit Adora's use of her powers or whatever.

"...and the police had to step in and stop several people from assaulting the suspected sorceress, leading to complaints about police brutality being raised in the county. The district's representative in Congress, Mrs Brown, released a communique stating that she would propose a bill to 'strictly regulate magic to ensure it didn't threaten the physical or spiritual well-being of the people' and refused to condemn what she called 'concerned citizens trying to defend themselves when the state refuses to take action', though…"

Jack O'Neill closed his eyes. Lynch mobs and witch hunts! "And here we thought that was a thing of the past. What's next, trying to outlaw D&D again?"

"...the rejuvenation of the Amazon basin continues on schedule according to the Brazilian government, citing new restoration technologies and a crack-down against illegal logging operations as the reason. They did not comment when questioned whether there was any truth to the rumour that several influential businessmen had been found dead in their beds, apparently killed by unknown magic, or why the government had refused to release information about which areas would be the next ones to have the rain forest restored, though they confirmed that Princess Perfuma of the Kingdom of Plumeria wasn't involved…"

If that was 'new technology', Jack would eat his shiny new helmet. And he knew it wasn't any of Perfuma's work - the Princess was tracked whenever she visited after a bunch of politicians finally understood what her control over plants actually meant. No, that stuff was magic, probably one of the old traditions of Earth he had heard about. And he would bet that this was payback for murdering environmental activists and inconvenient tribes. But no matter what it was, someone had to keep an eye on it in case it went any further. Especially if Brazil joined the Alliance, though that was a ways off at best, last he heard.

Well, his break was over now. Time to get back to work.

He sighed, turned the TV off and checked the next piece in his pile of mail. And then he sighed again. Great, some agricultural corporations wanted to develop cloning tanks to produce meat, allegedly so the Alliance could reduce the strain on its logistics by producing meat on the bases. And he was supposed to write a report about how that would affect Alliance Special Operations Command's missions?

He scoffed. His troops weren't deployed in numbers or locations that would make such production feasible. Which anyone trying to push this should know. Just as they should know he'd realise this was a thinly-veiled attempt to make the Alliance finance the research so the corporations then could sell the stuff to civilians.

Jack quickly typed a response that said it would be useless for his command. He didn't know if it would do anything, but he hoped it would. He didn't want to eat cloned meat. Whether in the field or at home.

He filed the report, then eyed the next item. Paperwork. How he hated it. If only the spooks would hurry up and find Ba'al's next base so he could get out of this!

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, June 8th, 2000

"...and while we haven't found one of Ba'al's bases so far, we did manage to acquire the address of one of his ship-mounted Stargates thanks to one of our operatives infiltrating Sokar's forces. If Ba'al keeps his bases off the Stargate network by using ships with Stargates stationed near their systems to allow faster travel, then this would mean one of his bases is near the ship's position."

Adora nodded at Jakar/Mats's report. The Tok'ra had come through, it seemed. Although… "How recent is the ship's address?" she asked.

"It's about two weeks old," Jakar said.

"Do we know how often those ships change their position?" Admiral Brown-Emerson asked. "If Ba'al's is keeping his bases compartmentalised, I doubt he's going to keep his ships at the same spot."

"He is likely moving them around quite a bit, but having his ships change between his bases would defeat his strategy of keeping them compartmentalised," Jakar replied. "So, we expect that this base is still within the same general area."

"If your address was taken when it was on station," Catra said.

“Yes. But since our operative could only secure this address, it is very likely that it is or at least was stationary for some time or there would have been more frequent updates,” Jakar told her.

Adora nodded again. A Stargate mounted on a ship could only be reached if you knew the position of the ship, well, the rough position. So, Alliance policy with the few ship-mounted Stargates they had was that they would regularly update their position in case someone needed to travel to them, either by dialling another Stargate or transmitting their position through the Spy Bot Network if they were in range. Ba'al would be faced with the same limitations. “We'll redirect the spy bots to search the area as soon as possible,” she said.

“We could try dialling the Stargate address we have and launch a boarding operation if it's still active,” General Naird suggested.

“I'm not going to send my troops through a Stargate without any intel about what awaits them,” Jack objected.

“According to your files from Stargate Command, you’ve done that more than once yourself, General O'Neill,” Naird retorted. “That was how you made contact with Etheria for the first time, wasn’t it?”

“In emergencies,” Jack shot back. “When there was no other choice. This isn't the case here.”

“Every day, Ba'al is growing stronger, according to our analysts. At some point, he will outnumber us and have equivalent technology unless we stop him as soon as possible. That seems like an emergency to me,” Naird said.

“Sending in a boarding force blind is too much of a risk,” Adora cut in. “Even if they managed to secure the ship without the crew scuttling it or escorts destroying it, the risk of the Jaffa on station alerting Ba'al before communications are secured is too high.” She wouldn't take such a gamble. They weren't desperate. “Besides, it

will only take a few days at most to search the area with the spy bots, now that we know where to look."

Naird pouted but seemed to accept that.

Catra whispered something about sending Naird first through the Stargate if he kept this up, and Adora had to stifle a chuckle.

"Once you have the position of the base, what will you do?" Jakar asked. "Will you take it over?"

"If there is a base," Naird said, a little snidely. "It's just an assumption so far."

"Taking over the base is a secondary goal. Our first goal is to get more information so we can dismantle his forces," Adora said. "He might keep all of them isolated, but they still have to report to him."

"You're planning a decapitation strike," Jakar said.

Adora nodded. "It seems the most effective way to deal with this threat. Take out the leader and have his forces wither on the vine."

"As long as we can secure his cloning facilities," Catra said.

"Yes," Adora agreed. "We will have to remain undetected until we have acquired the information we need before we strike, whether at the base or at Ba'al himself."

"Let's hope that this mission goes better than your last. Or the one before that," Admiral Biggs spoke up with a scowl. "You don't have the best track record lately."

Adora pressed her lips together. The man was correct, which was annoying since she couldn't contradict him.

"We still got a much better record, even on the latest mission, than your ships have." Catra, of course, didn't care about that.

“How much longer do we have to wait until your ‘frigates’ are operational?”

“The Constitution II is ready for combat operations in the Solar System!” Biggs shot back.

Adora frowned. Why would the ship be ready for deployment, but limited to the Solar System? Was something wrong with its hyperdrive? But that was essential for battles, not merely for travelling. So… Oh. “That would be an emergency,” she said. “But I don't remember the ship being ready for regular operations.”

Biggs glared at her for a moment. “We expect to be ready for regular operations outside the Solar System soon.”

Jack snorted, but neither he nor Catra pressed the point. Not that they had to - the troubles with the Constitution II-class were widely known at this point. Adora expected the press to pick up on it any day now, despite the information being classified - the Alliance couldn't really stop foreign news agencies. Not without becoming the dictatorship that other nations accused them of being.

But this had gone on for long enough. She smiled at Jakar. “Please convey our thanks to the Tok'ra and inform them of our plan of action.”

“I will, Supreme Commander!” Jakar bowed.

And now, they had a mission to plan. Or, to be more precise, adjust the general plans already made to the specific situation. Once they had the information they needed.

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Deep Space, Outside PT-9521, June 16th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Alright! Operation Lamprey is a go!”

Samantha Carter frowned at Entrapta's comment. It wasn't her friend's fault, of course - she hadn't named the operation. That had been the General. And Sam still disagreed with his claim that the Spy Bot Mark XI was a ‘robo-lamprey’. The bot could attach itself to an enemy ship, yes, and unlike the regular space-capable spy bots, it was flatter so the chance something - or someone - would catch on its surface was smaller, but those were the only similarities. The bot used a magitech tool to adhere to a ship's hull, not some suction technology, and it had an advanced stealth generator to hide its presence even up close.

And it was shaped like a flat disc with a slightly rounded topside, not like a fish. But Sam had been outvoted by the others.

Ultimately, it wasn't a big deal. It was one mission, and while writing the reports wouldn't be a little annoying, it would be far worse if the General had managed to nickname the entire line of bots ‘Lampreys’. That could still happen; Sam was aware of how such things worked, but for now, they were merely spy bots.

And they were the core part of the plan to deal with Ba'al. They better worked - Sam and Entrapta had had to delay working on the improved combat suits to do work on the bots, and even so, they were using hand-crafted prototypes for the mission.

“Launching spy bots!” Sam announced as she gave the order.

In the repurposed hangar of the frigate they were in, the half a dozen Mark XIs lifted off and left the ship, stealth fields flicking on as they vanished from view.

Sam switched her attention from the ship’s video feeds to the spy bot network’s data. The six new bots were already integrated, and she could track them through the network until they entered hyperspace, on their way to the Ha'tak Ba'al was using as a gate ship to access this area.

“Look at how eager they are!” Entrapta beamed. “I still think we should have made them smarter. They could do much more.”

Sam knew that the spy bots' capabilities would be significantly enhanced by a sapient control unit instead of a merely advanced decision matrix. It certainly would have increased the missions' odds of success.

But Adora had put her foot down - the Alliance wouldn't create sapient beings whose only purpose was to send on missions that were, if not outright suicide missions, then close enough. Sam was forced to agree; given her experience with sapient bots, she doubted that such spy bots would have been able to refuse such an order since that was what they were built for and identified as.

The General had agreed as well, though he had been concerned about spy bots going rogue, starting up their own network and taking over the galaxy - a very unlikely outcome, in Sam's opinion.

However, it meant the spy bot Mark XIs needed more precise orders and were far more limited in their capabilities. They should be enough for this, though, at least in the first phase - all they needed to do was to sneak up on the target and attach themselves to the ship's hull. In the next phase, they would have to split up once they detected other ships to latch on - as long as the ships were large enough for the spy bots to hide on the hull without triggering sensors due to the mass difference, which limited them to Ha'taks.

The entire mission was a bit of a shot in the dark. Using prototypes on crucial missions, trusting their luck, at least to some degree… It's almost like we're back in Stargate Command, Sam thought with a faint smile.

Sure, this time, they had fleets at their back, but if they failed, the consequences would still be grave. If they couldn't stop Ba'al before he ramped up his production pipelines for both ships and crews, they would have to match him, and that would open a whole can of worms, as the General put it. They could ramp up frigate production, and were already doing this to some degree in anticipation of further casualties, but a huge build-up would

require more crews than the Clones could provide given their current cloning rates. And that meant Earth crews.

At least, Sam thought with a scoff, in that case, the Navy would be forced to drop their boondoggle of a frigate design and switch to using stock Horde frigates, and Sam wouldn't have to waste time trying to fix whatever issue crept up this week.

An alert on her computer told her that the spy bots were about to drop out of hyperspace, and she focused on the screen, counting down.

Four… three… two… One… Zero.

The spy bots linked up with the network at once, and Sam checked their position - not quite on top of the target, as planned.

She followed on the slightly lagged feeds as they approached the Ha'tak. “Those aren't standard cannons,” she said.

“They aren't Horde beam cannons, though,” Entrapta pointed out. “Just upgraded Goa'uld designs. Slightly upgraded, or so it looked. And their sensors weren't upgraded either - they haven't noticed the bots!”

They better not have noticed them, Sam thought. If they had, that would have meant Ba'al had better sensors than the Alliance. And that would have been a catastrophe.

But as things were, the spy bots fanned out, picking locations on the hull to approach and latch onto, without anyone opening fire on them.

Soon, the last of them came to a stop, securely attached to the Ha'tak's hull.

Phase one of the mission was complete. Now they had to start phase two.

*****

Ba’al’s Machinations Part 3

Deep Space, Outside PT-9521-System, June 16th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“The spy bots have successfully attached themselves to the target.”

Watching the ship movements of the task force of First Fleet on its flagship's bridge, Catra grinned as she heard Sam's report. Phase 1 of the operation was complete - time for phase 2. The best way to get the Ha'tak with the Stargate in it to move to another of Ba'al's bases, or at least a rally spot for his fleet, was to remove the reason it was staying in this region of space.

“Begin Phase 2 of Operation Lamprey,” Adora ordered.

“Yes, Supreme Commander! Entering hyperspace in ten… nine… eight…”

Out of habit, Catra checked that all ships of the task force were ready as the countdown continued. No malfunctions were reported.

“...three… two… one…”

The task force entered hyperspace, and the link to the spy bot network was briefly scrambled, reestablishing itself as soon as they were travelling. She noticed no changes amongst the enemy guard ships - four Ha'taks, a dozen Al'kesh, and twice that number of Tel'taks. Even with upgraded systems, like the one Entrapta had reported, that wasn't enough to bother a task force half their size. Even if those ships were upgraded to full Horde technology, the outcome would be set in stone, but the odds of winning without taking significant damage to capital ships would be much lower and the odds of taking casualties higher.

But everyone in the task force knew this. Catra glanced at Adora. Her love was standing at parade rest, face serious and eyes fixed

on the big holoprojection in the centre of the bridge.

Catra was tempted to tease her a bit, but this was the largest planetary invasion the Alliance had launched in this war, and she knew Adora was already tense enough with worry.

So Catra just ran her tail over the back of Adora's leg as she stepped a little closer and watched as the holoprojection showed the task force's formation. The lead frigates were forming a wedge around the flagship, ready to pounce on the Goa'uld forces, and the frigates escorting the Fleet Transports were hanging back, covering their charges. Just as planned.

It didn't take them long to reach their destination. “Dropping out of hyperspace in five… four… three… two… one.”

The enemy ships had noticed their arrival a fraction of a second before the first frigates left hyperspace - not soon enough to react to the sudden attack as the Horde frigates came out firing, thanks to the feed from the spy bot network tracking the Goa'uld guard force. The lead frigates focused on two of the Ha'taks, multiple broadsides of beam cannons ripping through the shields and shredding the hulls of the massive ships.

One of them managed to return fire - a ragged, uneven volley, half the shots missing - before it blew up under the follow-up assault. The other was disabled at once, engine and reactor shredded by pinpoint attacks, and fell out of formation with wrecked sections trailing behind it.

That had given the other two Ha'taks and the supporting ships enough time to react, though, and the two Ha'taks quickly closed formation and started to focus their fire on the closest frigate while the supporting ships dove at the task force's edges.

“Switching to escorts,” the flag captain reported as the frigate's beam weapons started firing on the smaller ships charging them.

The improved beam cannons cut through the Al'kesh like Adora cut through bots. Less than half a dozen got into range of their

weapons, none close enough to drop their bombs, before they were all destroyed. The Tel'taks only survived to start firing on the frigates because they were more numerous and not priority targets.

"Eternal Vigilance, fall back! Lead elements, focus fire on the remaining Ha'taks!"

On the flag captain's command, the frigates turned their attention on the two Ha'taks, quickly shattering their shields with concentrated volleys. As the Ha'tak's hulls were holed in multiple locations, Catra checked the effect of the Tel'tak and Death Gliders strafing the task force.

The lead frigates's shields were slowly but steadily degrading under the fire. The escort elements, though, were quickly clearing the space around them, and the two Fleet Transports, HMS Albion and HMS Bulwark, were barely touched at all - a handful of Death Gliders had made it through the formation and were picked off by the transport's gunners.

The next Ha'tak vanishing in a cloud of gas and vaporised metal drew her attention back to the fight in the front just in time to see the last Ha'tak lose its engines. The ship continued on momentum alone, guns still firing, as the beam cannons' volleys punched into its fragmenting hull.

"Lead elements, Switch targets to Tel'taks and Death Gliders! Escorts, clear the orbitals."

The fire from the Death Gliders and Tel'taks quickly fell off as their pilots started trying to evade withering fire, half of them caught in a crossfire as the escorts and transports changed course for the planet's orbit and passed the lead frigates. A few Tel'taks and Death Gliders managed to form up for a focused attack on the transports - their leader must have realised what they were - but they were too few to seriously threaten either ship even if the escorts hadn't focused on them in a heartbeat.

When the last Ha'tak finally stopped firing, reduced to a floating wreck with all systems and power out, HMS Albion and her sister ship took up positions above the base on the planet below, launching shuttle after shuttle while their cannons silenced the planet's anti-air defences.

"I should be with the others," Adora mumbled.

"No. You can't be everywhere," Catra disagreed in a low voice. "They need to learn how to do this without you." The Alliance couldn't depend on having She-Ra present in every landing operation.

Adora frowned but didn't disagree, and Catra patted her back while the escorting frigates finished clearing the planet's orbit of the surviving Death Gliders.

*****

In Orbit above PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 16th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Jack O'Neill wouldn't say he had a problem. He knew that while he was a good pilot, others were better pilots. He also knew that as the officer in charge of phase two of Operation Lamprey, the invasion of PT-9521, he couldn't personally fly a shuttle even if he were the best pilot in the Alliance. And he trusted his fellow soldiers. Even the Navy pukes. But he drew the line at waiting safely in orbit - he wouldn't send his troops into danger without coming along! Besides, he knew that if he had to make a call, he wanted to be at the front and get a view of the situation up close and with his own eyes, not through reports and camera feeds.

He still didn't like the feeling of being a passenger sitting in the back of a craft while they dropped on the target and having to trust his life to the pilot at the front. Especially when they were shot at - everyone knew a shuttle was most vulnerable during re-entry. Even stealth shuttles couldn't hide during that part of a drop because of the plasma they produced when they hit the

atmosphere - the improved stealth systems still could only reduce that, not remove it.

And he and his troops from Alliance Special Operations Command were the first to descend on the planet, using stealth shuttles to drop ahead of the two British brigades that made up the main invasion force, so they were facing the brunt of the enemy fire by themselves.

Of course, the two limey Fleet Transports were suppressing the enemy anti-orbital and anti-aircraft fire with constant volleys from their beam cannons while fighters from the escorting frigates did attack runs and pounced on the few surviving Death Gliders left in the planet's atmosphere, so the odds of any of Ba'al's forces on the ground figuring out that the stealth shuttles' plasma trails were not the result of the bombardment or the fighters diving to the surface of the planet were fairly low. Jack still would have preferred it if they could have completely avoided the field of fire of the base defences, but the Alliance Command Council was worried about Ba'al figuring out their stealth technology and wanted more plausible cover for their plasma trails.

Which meant they had to risk getting hit by shots not aimed at them. And Ba'al's Jaffa were certainly trying - Jack could see on the screen mounted in front of his seat that the ground defenders were firing everything they had as fast as they could until their weapon emplacements were taken out.

So he gritted his teeth and tried not to think of the odds when his shuttle entered the atmosphere, directly behind the lead shuttle, and the outside view vanished in a fireball.

The sensors feeding his screen weren't affected, though, and he kept checking his troops while the half-a-dozen shuttles carrying his troops swung around the planet as they slowed down in the atmosphere. None were hit or reported any trouble, and by the time they re-entered the field of fire of the base's defences, they were too slow and too low to generate plasma any more. The Jaffa had no idea they were there.

Or shouldn’t have.

“Alright, folks,” he said into the communicator, “time to get busy! You know your targets, go in and secure them - and make doubly sure that your transponders are working; we don’t want the navy pukes accidentally hitting us!” ‘Danger Close’ was frightening when it came in the form of orbital bombardments.

As he had ordered his soldiers to, he checked his own transponder when the shuttle stopped, hovering above the ground. Campbell and Isa were the first ones out, Isa taking the lead - until they got the new armoured suits, she was the best-protected member of his forces.

Jack was right behind them, his carbine in hand. He dashed forward to the ridge shielding the base form view and quickly took an overview.

Craters, both big and small, lined the perimeter, and the wall had been breached so often, a full company could charge through without having to stop. It still provided the defenders with cover and ambush opportunities.

Or would if they were aware that the invasion had already begun. But with the heavy weapons mostly destroyed - there went another one, struck by a beam - they would hunker down to face the invasion they knew was coming.

Jack pulled out his tablet and flipped the feed from the Fleet Transports above them on. Yeah, the Jaffa were taking shelter and covering the breaches as well as they could. Well, the Limeys could deal with them - they had the tanks and artillery to push through. Jack wasn’t here to show them up; his forces had to find a way past the defenders so they could secure the base’s computers and communications before Ba’al’s Jaffa could destroy both.

He checked that all his troops were ready, then opened a channel to the ships above. “We’re in position, smoke them!”

"Copy."

Half a minute later, missiles struck the base - and released thick clouds of smoke that soon merged, covering the entire base.

Jack switched the thermographic vision mode of his visor on and grinned as he went over the ridge.

"Go Go Go! Move!"

They charged down the ridge. At any moment, Jack expected someone to spot them - parts of the base were not completely covered in smoke - and raise the alert. To see the weapon emplacements left start laying down covering fire or to blindly open fire into pre-selected sectors. But they made it down the ridge and halfway across the open field to the remains to the walls without anyone shooting at them, or even just in their general direction.

If he were in charge of the base defence, he'd have rigged the field with anti-personnel mines, too, but they had scanned for that.

But a few yards before Isa - that woman was fast! Even carrying a heavy machine gun and a missile launcher, she outpaced him! - reached the wall, Jack saw figures move in the smoke, taking up firing positions. "Watch out!" he snapped into the communicator. "We've been made."

Moments later, staff blasts tore through the smoke and into the field, blowing up chunks of dirt and stone. Unaimed fire, he realised at once. But that could kill you as dead as aimed fire if you were unlucky. And the closer they got to the wall, the closer the shots would get to them.

He really wished they had the new armour suits already when he heard a scream, followed by a call for a medic, over the comm.

Isa returned fire with the heavy machine gun, running diagonally across the breach towards the wall. Jack saw a few flashes from

the tracer rounds, and two figures collapsed in the smoke.

That cut down on the fire somewhat, and Jack reached the wall on the other side of the breach ahead of Campbell. "Fire in the hole!" he yelled, drawing a grenade from his pouch. He pulled the pin and threw it around the edge of the wall.

A few seconds later, it went off, and he felt the shock wave in his chest before he jumped up and rounded the corner, leading with his gun.

Two Jaffa down but moving - he put two rounds into the closer, Campbell finishing off the second. On their right side, Isa - no one else was that large - pushed ahead, her machine gun firing in short bursts.

To Jack's left, something moved, and he dropped to the ground. A staff blast passed overhead, and he returned fire, dropping the Jaffa, who had taken up a firing position behind the wreck of a cannon with another burst to the head and neck.

Then Campbell dashed forward, throwing himself into cover behind the cannon. "Fire in the hole!"

The grenade flew over the wreckage, and two Jaffa, one to each side, dashed out from behind it. Jack dropped the left one with four rounds in the chest, Campbell caught the other in the legs, but the Jaffa fired back while falling, and the cannon's twisted barrel next to Campbell blew up.

The man cried out, holding his head, as he sat down, and Jack rushed over. In the smoke, he couldn't check the wounds, and so he called for a medic and left a beacon on the groaning man. Isa turned around - he could see that in the smoke with his thermographic vision - but he waved her on. "Go! We've got our targets!"

She jerked but continued toward their target - the main communication centre - firing a few more bursts upwards while she ran.

Jack followed her, shooting at the Jaffa on the roof as well, but he couldn't tell if he hit anyone or if they had just dropped into cover. He took a position on Isa's left at a corner of the main building, checking for more enemies.

There were still too many Jaffa up and fighting here - he spotted a group running across the street to the side - and if they massed their forces, Jack's troops would be done for.

He checked the tablet for a brief look at the overall situation. A few more minutes until the assault shuttles would hit the ground. And the second group of his force had just reached the main computer centre or whatever the Jaffa called it. Above them, the British brigades were dropping as well now - and their shuttles were visible to sensors. If the Jaffa pulled back from their other positions, they'd be overrun in no time.

However, Jack wasn't sure they knew that. And there were enough Jaffa at the main entrance that charging that with his… three other soldiers, two more had joined him and Isa, would be suicide.

Well, time to make a new entrance then. He moved back, sending Meier to cover the corner, then pulled out the 'wallbuster' charge prepared in advance and slapped it on the wall in the centre. "Take cover!"

A few seconds later, everyone was hugging the ground, and Jack triggered the detonator.

Compared to the grenade, this explosion was much more powerful - Jack was a bit too close, and the shock wave felt like a punch to the stomach - but it did the job, and he was charging toward the hole in the wall before the dust settled.

Isa beat him to the punch, though, and entered with her machine gun firing. Jack followed, going left, Meier, behind him, taking the right side.

A squad of Jaffa rushed around the corner, and Jack dropped to the ground, clenching his teeth as he opened up with a long burst that took three of them down. The fourth got a shot off that came way too close to Jack. He felt the heat from the blast on his cheek before he got him as well with a couple of bullets to the chest.

He did a tactical reload while getting up and checked the rest. Meier was down with a shot leg, but Isa had tied a tourniquet around his thigh, and he'd be fine.

But they couldn't leave him here. "Take him," Jack snapped.

While Isa grabbed Meier - he protested, claiming he could hold the breach - Jack dashed ahead to the stairway in the distance. The main computer would be down below.

He reached the stairs despite a Jaffa firing a zat at him - twice, before Meier or Isa got the bastard - and raced down.

He kicked the door open, ducked back - no shots missed him - and then used a small mirror to check the place.

Rows upon rows of snake computers and FTL communicators, no living soul.

Good. "We've secured the comm centre," he announced. "Need relief as soon as possible."

"Copy."

Jack hoped the Fleet was on the ball here. He didn't want to reenact Market Garden.

*****

PT-9521-System, June 16th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Base communications and data centre secured, Supreme Commander. Awaiting relief."

Adora nodded at the report. Jack's troops had reached their objectives. But they were a small force and had to hold out until the two British brigades arrived. They had started the landing operations - the first wave's shuttles had just finished re-entry and were about to drop on the assigned landing zone - but it would still take some more time until the base was taken. She bit her lower lip, watching the troop deployments on the holoprojection. If she dropped directly into the base…

"You can divert a company to land directly inside the base," Catra commented. "That would be faster than flying down yourself."

When Adora frowned at her, Catra smirked. "I know what you're thinking."

Adora huffed and checked the status of the landing again. She could divert a company from the reserves in the first wave, but if they needed those units to reinforce a thrust or cover a hole in the formation, that could cause a lot of problems. And get more people killed. "Divert two empty shuttles to serve as close air support."

"Yes, Supreme Commander!"

That would require adjustments to the second wave's deployment, but they had planned with losing shuttles to enemy fire in mind, so it shouldn't be a big problem - they hadn't lost any shuttle outright, but two had taken fire and needed repairs before they could be used again.

"That's not much firepower, though," Catra said. "We should produce some assault shuttles for ground support for those missions. If we can spare the production."

That was a big if. They still lacked enough transport capacity for their available ground formations. Infantry, vehicles, medevac, supplies, ammunition and tankers… everyone wanted transport shuttles. Even on planets with a Stargate, a shuttle was often better to carry supplies to outposts than a ground-based

transport, what with worlds controlled by the Goa'uld often lacking decent roads. Or even decent dirt tracks. While they had designs for an assault shuttle, it wasn't a priority. Horde fighters and orbital fire support were supposed to cover that.

But Adora didn't trust either not to blow up parts of the base they wanted intact if they provided said fire support. Sure, if they had to blow up the base to save people, Adora would do it in a heartbeat, but they shouldn't have to make that choice.

On the holoprojection, two icons representing shuttles changed course and moved over the base. A few icons depicting enemy soldiers blinked out soon afterwards, and the rings of Jaffa surrounding the buildings taken by Jack's forces shifted as a result.

"We've destroyed their anti-air network," Catra said.

That didn't mean the shuttles were safe, though - the Jaffa's staff weapons could, if used in bulk, overwhelm a shuttle's shields. And the shuttles had to slow down to target enemies on the ground, making them vulnerable.

Case in point, Adora could see one of the shuttles suddenly jerk to the side in an obvious evasive action and the other changing course to support it. If it were shot down, that would be on her.

But the first wave was now advancing on a broad front, tanks and IFVs deployed and engaging entrenched enemies. Adora watched as the enemy line crumbled, most Jaffa dying in place - or at least rendered incapable of fighting - while a few tried to retreat under fire.

"There goes the main gate," Catra said. "They've broken into the base."

That meant combat at close range in urban terrain - pretty much the worst kind of combat against inferior forces. But it also meant that the Jaffa attacking Jack were now caught between two forces.

And one of those forces had tanks and IFVs with them. It only took a few positions getting blown up by direct fire for the remaining Jaffa to spread out and try to evade the trap.

Not many did.

"We're not getting many surrenders," Catra said. "Sure, we're assaulting and relieving the special forces, but… Apophis's forces had more Jaffa surrender in similar conditions."

Similar but not the same - Adora had fought personally in past invasions. "Maybe I should have gone in as well," she said as she watched the British soldiers take control of the base, starting with the buildings Jack had secured.

Catra didn't reply, but when Adora glanced at her, she saw that her lover was frowning. So, she probably was thinking the same thing.

Something to bring up during the debriefings. But, more importantly… "Did the gate ship move yet?"

"They received the emergency transmission from the base, but they haven't taken any action so far, Supreme Commander."

"Probably waiting for orders," Catra said. "Wouldn't want to retreat without permission. That gets you executed in some armies."

Adora nodded. Ba'al was supposed to be a fearsome Goa'uld. And the gateship was - or so they would think - safely hiding out of reach.

But a few minutes later, the Ha'tak with the Stargate left their position and entered hyperspace.

"Phase two complete. Primary and secondary objectives achieved, Supreme Commander."

Now, they could only hope that the spy bots would succeed. And that they could repel the counter-attack Adora was sure would be

coming.

*****

Ba’al’s Base, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 16th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Secure the area!”

The ramp fell down, and the soldiers inside the shuttle piled out. Samantha Carter didn’t really pay attention as they fanned out, staying focused on the HUD display on her visor, fed from the upgraded laptop in her armoured backpack.

The base was supposed to be secure, more or less - there were still some suspected holdouts in the sewers, and she was happy she didn’t have to dig them out - but the upper area and main buildings had been searched thoroughly by the General’s troops and the British landing force before Sam’s shuttle had reached planetary orbit from where she had been supervising phase one of the operation.

She still ducked when she got the go-ahead from the soldier at the ramp and ran toward the building’s entrance in front of her, shielded by a Challenger 2 and three Warriors. All of them adequate for fighting the Goa’uld, she noted as she entered the building, though the IFVs would be vulnerable to well-placed staff blasts without the added shield projectors. But compared to Horde technology, they were obsolete. And Ba’al had access to Horde technology.

Not to mention, adding shield projectors to tanks and IFVs was a kludge compared to vehicles designed with advanced technology in mind, such as shuttles.

She pushed the stray thoughts away and focused on the task at hand as she passed through the entrance hall of the building, which had suffered a bit in the fighting - as had the guards; she saw half a dozen dead Jaffa in a corner, covered somewhat with

torn drapes. However, she also saw two wounded soldiers apparently awaiting medevac. Special Forces, not British infantry.

“Ah, Carter!”

And there was the General. “Sir!” she nodded at him.

“We’ve got the comms secured but didn’t touch them, so if anything is broken, it wasn’t us!” He grinned.

“Yes, sir.” She didn’t smile; they were in the middle of an invasion, and she had a job to do. But she felt better.

She followed him down the stairs guarded by two soldiers.

“So, any news from the space part of the invasion?”

She knew which part he meant. Phase one. But that was classified, and they knew better than to talk about it in the field, in a facility they had just taken from the enemy. “We expect an enemy reaction, but we don’t know when it will happen.” No news yet from the bots.

“Ah. Well, that’s up to the Navy pukes, then.”

They reached a door guarded by two more soldiers - Isa and another trooper she didn’t recognise.

“Campbell was wounded, but he’ll make it,” the General said before she could decide to ask.

“Ah.”

“He better make it!” Isa growled. “He owes me lunch!”

Sam chuckled. It was what you did when people joked about such things to cope with stark reminders that every combat mission carried the risk of getting killed.

“Adora will probably wave her magic sword and cure him. He won’t get to laze around in the hospital ship,” the General said.

Then they were inside. The comm room didn't show any battle damage, not even bloodstains. Sam appreciated it, of course - trying to get any useful data out of broken consoles and shattered memory crystals was usually an exercise in frustration and futility but occasionally yielded results, so you had to make an attempt every time.

"We know they managed to get an emergency notice off," the General said, "but not if they managed to delete the memory."

The first thing had been planned - they had to alert the Ha'tak with the Stargate so it would move and lead the bots to another location. The second was a risk they had to take to get the first. She went to the main console and checked the screen. Yes, it was reporting a memory deletion. But.. She crouched down, checking the connectors in the back. The system was usually easier to penetrate through the data lines, especially the transmission caches. And while the caches were supposed to be cleared, they were also supposed to ensure the messages got through, and that often led to some data fragments remaining in the cache until overwritten by the next transmission - which never happened here.

Sam grinned as she started copying the data. If the Goa'uld had more competent IT staff, her job would be much harder. But the System Lords often selected for loyalty first, expertise second. Not without good reason, of course - controlling communications and information made it easier to launch a coup.

She skimmed the data. It was encrypted, but they had already broken that code when they intercepted the transmission on the Ha'tak. And this data contained some markers and headers that weren't sent but could give information about other recipients.

"Done," she announced. "We can move to the base's main computer building."

There would be the real prize.

The General grimaced. “About that…”

Sam pressed her lips together. She already knew she wouldn’t like it.

“The fighting was a bit more intense there, and the Jaffa had a bit more time. So, it’s not as if all computers got broken, but…”

As she had feared, another frustrating task awaited her.

*****

Former Ba’al’s Base, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 16th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“We have managed to secure the physical facilities. They were damaged during the fighting but not beyond local capabilities to restore. Unfortunately, despite our best efforts, the defenders managed to inflict significant damage to the memory crystals in the central data centre. We’ve managed to recover extensive records, but key parts were lost. We expect to be able to use the other shipyard we’ve captured to restore the missing data, though this will require careful checks and will delay the recommissioning of the shipyards here.”

Catra nodded as Sam finished her preliminary report - she knew her friend would deliver a much more detailed one, but she only needed the big picture here. The fiddly bits could be left to others. Not for the first time, she compared the Alliance to the Horde. The difference between working with people who were as likely to lie to you, either in an attempt to sabotage you so they could replace you or to hide a mistake they made to escape punishment, and people you could trust to tell you the truth of the situation on the ground was staggering.

“Thank you, Sam,” Adora said, smiling. “Good work.”

Sam winced. “We should have been quicker. If I had been with the special forces…”

“The damage was done before we managed to secure the room,” Jack cut her off. “You being with us wouldn’t have changed that.”

Sam obviously didn’t like it, but she acknowledged it with a nod. “Yes, sir.”

“We did secure the base and the shipyards mostly intact,” Adora said.

“And we did deny it to Ba’al,” Catra added. The base must have cost him significant resources to set up - both material and personnel. They still didn’t know the extent of his resources, but losing two entire shipyards was bound to put a dent in them. And, speaking of personnel… “Resistance was heavier than expected, wasn’t it?”

It was Jack’s turn to grimace. “Yeah. The Jaffa fought harder than the ones we beat before. Even for Jaffa, they were fanatical.”

“They fought as one would expect the chosen personal guard of a false god to fight - to the death,” Teal’c added. “Yet, they lacked such an elevated status and served in common positions.”

“All Jaffa are expected to fight to the death, aren’t they?” Brigadier Hughes asked. This had been his first battle in the war against the Goa’uld, Catra knew.

“They are, but…” Jack shrugged. “Not all of them actually do. There’s always a couple who reconsider the dying for their god part when things get tight.”

Catra nodded. Either because they weren’t quite as fanatical as they claimed to be or because shell shock didn’t spare Jaffa, either. “But we had significantly fewer such surrenders here, right?” That had been in the first reports.

“Yeah.”

“We’re still in the process of determining whether this is due to increased efforts by Ba’al to ensure loyalty unto death or if there

are other factors in play," Major Bellheim, the officer in charge of the intel efforts in the invasion, added. "However, we've also noticed a higher rate of uncooperative civilians than in similar cases."

And that would add even more delays until the shipyard could restart production. Trained staff was much harder to replace, even if you added the cost of retraining them to produce Alliance craft.

"We've preliminarily identified one factor that might be responsible, at least in part, for the increased resistance to our efforts to, ah, convert the prisoners to our side," the Major went on.

Ah. Catra snorted. "There was no She-Ra to awe the Jaffa and slaves into abandoning their god for Her Divine Highness."

"Yes, ma'am."

Next to her, Adora sighed.

"Well, on the positive side, that's one more reason for you to fight at the front in such operations," Jack said,

Catra rolled her eyes when Adora perked up. Of course, she'd like that! "Well, releasing the planet's magic should help with shaking the prisoner's faith in Ba'al," she said.

And Adora sighed again.

Tough, Catra thought. If she wanted to win the war as quickly as possible, her lover better had to get used to this - it was their best way to turn enemies into allies.

And, though Catra wouldn't say that out loud, not here, not on Earth and not on Etheria, the more people followed She-Ra, the better Etheria's position would be after the war.

Something one had to keep in mind as well. It wouldn't do to win the war and lose the peace. She trusted their friends from Earth,

but that world had far too many nutcases, in her opinion.

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Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 18th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Some of the limeys at the meeting were still sneaking glances at the sight outside the base as if they had never seen She-Ra's magic at work. Well, they probably hadn't, Jack O'Neill admitted - both brigades had seen their first battle in this war. It was hard not to grow a bit blasé about world-shaping magic if you encountered it every other day - well, it felt like that, at least.

Of course, his own people were making a point of acting as if turning the entire region into lush fields instead of dry, near-desert plains, supplied with water from changed hills and mountains around it was nothing special at all. Had to show up the new guys.

It was harmless and helped with the esprit de corps. Napoleon had said, the moral was to the physical as three was to one. Jack wasn't quite as sure; there was a reason people also said that providence was always on the side of the big battalions. Even the best morale couldn't won against all odds, as this base assault had proven; Ba'al's soldiers were fanatical, but they hadn't been able to stop, much less defeat the landing force.

They had been able to blood them, though - casualties had been higher than projected, both for Jack's own forces and the two brigades. Not quite as bad as failed landing operations could get, not nearly so, but still worse than they should have been, given their numerical and technological superiority. There was only so much you could do if an enemy was willing to die to hurt you - and was holed up in a building you couldn't just flatten with air support or artillery.

He spotted the last missing officer entering the meeting room, Major Bellheim. The Intel guy looked more like a nerd than James

Bond, and his service file confirmed the impression - not much field experience, but a great analyst.

Time to get this show on the road.

Jack cleared his throat. “Alright. Now that everyone is here, let's have your reports. How are things in our shiny new base?”

His own people chuckled, but most of the limeys looked a little annoyed. Well, Jack was the officer in charge, and if he liked to be less formal, that was his privilege. Besides, they had better get used to it, or they would not survive working under some of the princesses. On the other hand, those people were used to serving a queen, so they probably would get along well with the more royal-minded princesses.

Whatever! He looked at Major Bellheim. “Last in, first out. How's the situation with the prisoners?”

Bellheim didn't miss a beat or react to the slight ribbing about being the last to arrive even though he had still been on time. “As expected, Princess She-Ra's demonstration had a significant effect on the prisoners taken in the assault, aided by the fact that we could prepare for it beforehand and arrange the best conditions for the prisoners to watch. Most of the civilian workers seem to have abandoned their faith in Ba'al and converted to worshipping She-Ra. We can't tell yet what impressed them more; the alterations done to the landscape or the healing, the sheer number of people to process and vet will keep my unit busy for the foreseeable future.” He smiled apologetically. “We decided that a strict process was necessary after the initial resistance proved stronger than expected.”

“This will mean we won't be able to have the workers aid with restoring the damaged parts of the yards,” Captain Baum, a Navy Puke sent here to oversee the shipyards, cut in.

“Yes.” Bellheim nodded and ignored Baum's scowl.

Jack considered reminding Baum that they could ask the workers to help but couldn't really count on that, but decided against it. Odds were, the new converts would help out anyway. “What about the Jaffa?”

Bellheim’s expression didn't change. “Reactions were mixed. Most positive were those from the wounded, though as we have been able to confirm, Ba'al does allow some of his warriors to be treated in a Sarcophagus. Hence, the psychological effect of receiving magical healing was less pronounced than in other incidents. Nevertheless, coupled with the changes to the area outside the base, we estimate that a significant number of the prisoners have changed allegiance or will do so soon, but we keep all of them under close scrutiny and have expedited their transfer to safe holding facilities.”

Jack agreed - most prisoners had surrendered because they had not been willing to die for Ba'al, so they had been halfway to betraying their god already. But the prisoners who had been captured because they had been unconscious or too wounded to keep fighting were another thing.

He waited, and when Bellheim didn’t add anything, he turned to the next officer, Colonel Carson. “Now, what’s the status of our defences?”

“We're replacing the destroyed heavy weapons with our own systems, focusing on anti-aircraft and anti-infantry systems. With the task force in orbit, the need for heavier defences is not quite as pressing. We should have adequate cover against a division-sized attack with dozens of Death Gliders in two to three days - setting up the power supplies for the systems takes longer than estimated in some cases.”

Well, Jack was curious if Carson would say the same once Ba'al's counter-attack started, but the Colonel wasn't wrong that shoring up the defences against a ground attack with air support was the priority right now. “Good. And, speaking of supplies…”

He already knew the gist of everything, but it was always good to have more details. Jack would rather not discover a problem in the middle of an attack if he could help it. Ba'al would create enough issues on his own; Jack was sure of that.

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Ba’al’s Machinations Part 4

PT-9521-System, June 20th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“And here you can see how the spy bots detach and fan out to other ships - well, what you see is a depiction of the scene since they are using their stealth generators, but it works out the same, well, to visualise it - the system is, because of lag and the inherent loss of precision by not having constant data feeds of their positions, but regular micro-bursts to avoid detection, so the positions have to be updated with the actual data in regular intervals, which is why the bots seem to jerk a little on the display.”

“Ah.” Adora hadn’t noticed that. And she didn’t think it was very important - they weren’t about to shoot on their own bots. Not that the bots were armed, except for their self-destruct charges.

“I see,” Catra commented. She was probably exaggerating - her eyes were good, but not *that* good.

“I thought you would!” Entrapta beamed at them. “Anyway! Four hours ago, the spy bots detected other ships - plenty of them! So, all but one detached from the first ship and looked for other targets. And they remained undetected!”

“The plan is working, then.” Adora smiled.

“We’ll know once they report back in, which they will do once their new ships move. Or if they get destroyed, but we hope that won’t happen,” Entrapta went on. “Although so far, they haven’t moved. But we’re already moving the regular spy bots into the area so they can begin searching for another base.”

Adora nodded. This was apparently a rally spot - the other ships had arrived in two waves - but those new ships had to have come from somewhere, somewhere close enough to travel from there to this spot in the time since the distress call from this system went

out. That… was still a huge area to search, but odds were, the ships had been guarding something in the area, or the Ha'tak carrying the Stargate would probably have travelled to their original rally spot instead of meeting them in deep space.

"Any chance with hacking the Ha'tak's system?" Catra asked.

Entrapta pouted. "We're trying, but with the lag, the infrequent communication, and the lack of a direct line to the ship's systems, it's not going well."

Adora hadn't expected anything else; it had always been a very long shot.

"Well, the bots are observing and waiting for further movement," Entrapta went on. "And looking for other ships to latch on, though so far there haven't been any new arrivals that were deemed more interesting than the Ha'taks and Al'Keshs there. A transport ship would be best since that would have to go to a base to pick up supplies, but so far, we only saw warships, well, ships that usually were used as warships. So…"

A beep from her tool interrupted her.

"Oh! More data! Let me just check and then push it on the display… There!"

Adora stared. The number of ships had increased again. Significantly. And they weren't just Goa'uld ships - she could see half a dozen Horde frigates amongst the ships displayed on the holoprojection.

Catra cursed. "That's a task force being assembled from several sources. And unless Ba'al has another huge problem to deal with on this side of his realm, those ships are going to hit us."

They didn't know how large Ba'als realm was, so those ships could be meant for another battle. But they hadn't heard about any attack by Sokar from the Tok'ra, and she was sure Ba'al wouldn't open another front after losing two shipyards to the Alliance… Not

unless it was some attempt to set the Alliance against another Goa'uls, of course, but did he know enough about the Alliance to try it?

She didn't think so. And the first base they liberated was further away from the spy bots' position than Base Portsmouth in this system, she reminded herself. "They're coming after us," she said.

"And it looks like they'll come with enough ships to give us trouble," Catra added.

Adora nodded. "We'll have to evacuate the civilians and prisoners of war. And prepare." Reinforcements were on the way, but they would likely not arrive in time unless Ba'al's forces waited a few more days. And the base still lacked anti-orbital weapons, so there wouldn't be any support from the planet.

"This will be tricky," Catra said, flashing her fangs in a familiar toothy grin.

*****

Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 20th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter was a great scientist. This wasn't a self-aggrandising boast; it was an objective fact. She had the record - and the requests for help from various parts of the military-industrial complex - to prove it. But she couldn't do miracles. And people needed to understand that.

"No, sir, we can't get the shipyard going and produce guns that we then can turn into anti-orbital artillery batteries in two days," she explained to the General. "Yes, it's theoretically possible - we can adapt the fire control system and cobble together a mount so they could engage targets from the ground - but even if the shipyards were fully restored and we managed to reprogram the controls, we still would have to physically adjust an existing line to produce the mounts and train the staff on how to assemble the finished cannon. And that's only if we can do it with existing parts

and supplies." She shook her head. "We can't do it in two days, and even if we managed, we'd only get a couple ready for deployment."

"That would be more than we currently have," the General replied. "We won't get any reinforcements from the Alliance in that time."

Sam was aware of that - she had run the calculations herself. "I think we have a better option to shift the odds in our favour, sir."

"Oh?" He smiled. "Let's hear it, Carter!"

"We could assemble and modify a dozen or more spy bots with charges strong enough to disable or outright destroy smaller ships and damage or cripple Ha'taks, but that would pose a significant risk of revealing our stealth capabilities to the enemy, sir." Sam felt guilty for dashing his hopes, but it had to be said - not that he wouldn't see the problem right away anyway.

His smile faded. "Yeah, I can see the problem. We're relying on our superior sensors and stealth for a lot of operations." He rubbed his chin. "But we risk exposure with every stealth shuttle we drop on an enemy planet. On the other hand, the bots would have to reach a ship first - and unless you managed to modify their engines so much, NASCAR is trying to poach you, I think they would have a bit of trouble with that, smack in the middle of combat. And they would have to get past the enemy shields, right?"

"Yes, sir. Although, since they will be attacking us, it shouldn't be too much of a problem to get them in range - we would effectively lay a minefield," Sam said. "We're already preparing to jump them as soon as they drop out of hyperspace thanks to our advance warning." But even a perfect ambush with their entire force in the system wouldn't be able to destroy enough of the force Ba'al was amassing to be able to finish them off with minimal casualties. Sam had run those calculations as well.

“I’m hearing a lot of ‘ifs’ and ‘shouldn’ts’, Carter.” He looked slightly disappointed.

“I’m sorry, sir, but as far as jury-rigging existing weapon systems to help us in the coming battle is concerned, even the best option leaves much to be desired.” Sam tilted her head slightly.

He nodded, then grinned at Entrapta. “But you look like you can’t hold back much longer. So, I guess you have something else in mind.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded rapidly. “We first thought about moving the Dimensional Portal generator here - we could have sent half their ships - I mean, halves of their ships - in another dimension. But we would take too long to disassemble it so it can fit through a Stargate and then reassemble it here. And Beta still has issues with targeting moving targets. But! You know how using the Dimensional Portal Generator shuts down Ring Transporters and other similar devices which rely on multi-dimensional effects, right?”

“I remember that mission, yes,” the General said with a slightly too-teethy smile. He didn’t like it when he felt talked down to - even though this was just Entrapta being Entrapta. She didn’t mean anything by it; she was just checking if people were aware of something she relied on.

“Right!” She beamed at him. “Anyway, so we thought that one of the advantages Ba’al’s task force has is numbers, but numbers require coordination - we had that problem in the Horde, when we sent in waves of bots and people, and they ended up shooting each other by mistake. Or didn’t find the enemy. And if the Alliance managed to focus, they could defeat them in detail. Anyway! So, without coordination, their bigger numbers won’t do much as long as we can coordinate our forces. And to disrupt their coordination, we just need to disrupt their communication and sensors. If they can’t talk to each other and can’t see us, they can’t coordinate.”

"As long as we can talk to each other and see the enemy," the General said.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "That's the main issue. But we're pretty sure we figured a way out to solve that!"

"'Pretty sure'?" He raised his eyebrows at Sam.

She didn't blush. "We cannot give you any guarantees. In theory, it should work, but we cannot test it; there's no time for that - the preparations are quite complex." And quite difficult, but she was certain they could do it.

"Alright, no need to confuse me with tech talk. So… we're betting everything on your idea working on the first try?" He grinned, and before she could tell him her estimates on their chances of success, he nodded. "Fine by me. Let's sell it to Adora and the others!"

Sam nodded, pleased - and slightly embarrassed - by his trust. Though she couldn't help being a bit worried.

She wasn't perfect, after all.

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Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 21st, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Ba'al's task force has entered hyperspace. We're tracking them through the spy bot network - as long as they are in range."

"So much for the hope that they'll delay their attack until we get reinforcements," Catra muttered in response to the report from the task force orbiting the planet.

"Well… we don't know if they are actually going to attack us here," Adora said. "Everything points to it, of course, but they could be attacking another system?" she added with a grimace.

Catra rolled her eyes. “We’re in the only base in the area.”

“That we know of,” Jack said.

“Do you think there is another base in this area of the sector? It would have to be very well hidden,” Entrapta spoke up. “Since we focused our spy bot network’s expansion on this area, so we’ve covered the systems thoroughly. Although I guess that they could have placed a base into deep space, so we would have to rely on long-range sensors, and they don’t cover quite everything - the longer the range, the smaller the area they can cover, actually. It’s physics. But! It would be great if we discover another base like this one! Or a research base.”

“I hope Ba’al doesn’t have any bases in the vicinity that are hidden from our sensors,” Jack said.

Catra agreed with him. If Ba’al had a way to hide entire bases from their sensor network, the whole war changed - hell, even the ability to hide a ship would be a game changer, depending on the range at which it could evade detection.

“It’s unlikely,” Sam said. “He would have used that capability to strike at us and his other enemies before.”

“Unless he saved it for a special occasion - like losing a second shipyard,” Jack countered. “Does anyone feel special?”

Catra snorted. She wouldn’t put it past Ba’al to do such a thing - the clone was pretty messed up and had revealed some really convoluted plans in his attempt to escape - but somehow, she doubted it. “If he is holding such a secret weapon back, he wouldn’t waste it on a single attack - he’d attack along the entire front, with his entire force.” That’s what she would do. Maximise the impact. Keep attacking so the enemy was forced to constantly react and couldn’t easily adapt.

“Unless he thinks he can deal with us without any witnesses escaping,” Jack said.

He was pretty gloomy today, Catra noted. “Anyway,” she said. “What’s their ETA?”

“Roughly two days until they reach the system. We can’t tell yet how many navigational stops, if any, they’ll take or if they abandon standard doctrine and attack directly into the system,” Sam replied.

Catra had hoped for something more precise, but she knew how hyperspace long-range travel worked.

Adora cleared her throat. “What’s the status of the Jammer?”

“Project Jam,” Jack commented.

Sam ignored his remark. “We’re on schedule.”

Meaning, it would be close. If the Goa’uld fleet was faster or more reckless than expected, they would arrive before the jammer was ready. And if they sent the Horde ships with them ahead, that would cause even more disruptions. But it would also cost Ba’al those Horde frigates, so she didn’t think he’d do it. Unless he wanted to get rid of some troublesome Clone, of course. No, he probably needed the ships more than that. Unless he had upgraded Ha’taks around already…

She shook her head. She couldn’t let her imagination drive herself crazy with worry. They’d tackle whatever Ba’al threw at them. “Pulling the ships back to the planet?” They had gone over that but hadn’t finalised it.

Adora nodded. “There’s nothing else in the system that needs protection.”

Catra agreed. That plan also meant they didn’t have a chance to attack the enemy when they dropped out of hyperspace, but that was only a slim chance to begin with. Unless Ba’al dropped his force straight on top of the planet, he could drop out anywhere he pleased in the system and still be safe from an ambush.

She looked at the holographic display. Ba'al's fleet was in formation in hyperspace. That didn't guarantee that they came out in the same formation, but they had decent odds. Horde frigates in the front, Ha'taks behind them. Weird - Catra would have used the frigates as flankers and the Ha'tak's as the centre. Sure, frigates could take more before being destroyed, but they were much harder to replace - or supposed to be.

"I don't like this," she said, pointing at the holoprojection. "We're missing something here."

"It's a straightforward formation," Sam replied. "Effective and appropriate."

"Yes," Catra agreed. "But that's Ba'al. He doesn't strike me as the kind of guy who would do something simple if he could do something complicated and twisted instead.

The others frowned, and Jack sighed. "I think you have a point. Now, let's brainstorm what Ba'al could be planning…"

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Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 23rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Enemy arrival imminent."

Jack O'Neill pressed his lips together so he wouldn't snap at the noncom reporting from the sensors console. He could see that for himself - the holographic display they had mounted in the command centre of the base showed the position of Ba'al's task force in hyperspace and he could see how fast they were closing in. Carter might insist that it was merely a display, that the enemy ships were not travelling down that path because hyperspace wasn't exactly part of this dimension, but it worked well enough for government work and tactics.

But the noncom was just doing her job, and Jack was doing his. Which, right now, consisted of doing nothing in his shiny new

base together with the other ground forces while the ships above - and his friends and teammates - prepared to fight a numerically superior force which also might have received upgrades to largely negate the Alliance's technological advantage.

"We should have gone with Operation Boarding," he muttered under his breath.

"Pardon?" The nominal base commander - Jack was in charge of all ground operations - was looking at him.

"Nothing, Brigadier," Jack replied. His proposal to use stealth shuttles to board enemy ships had been rejected. Well, to be honest, the chances of being able to board a ship in combat without taking out its shields and engines beforehand were not good. As in 'Hail Mary suicide mission' not good. And if a ship had lost both engines and shields… Well, then the ship was helpless anyway and another volley from being finished for good.

But it would have let Jack be in space and not stuck on the ground, watching his friends soon fight for their lives - and his - while he couldn't do a thing. The Alliance really needed some anti-orbital artillery. Perhaps a mobile missile launcher with stealth torpedoes… but that would risk exposing their stealth technology.

Damn it. He watched as the Alliance task force moved to envelop the rough area where the enemy fleet was projected to drop from hyperspace. Any moment now.

"Enemy fleet dropping from hyperspace!"

Here they came! But…

"Enemy ships separating from the main body!"

Half a dozen ships continued their trip through hyperspace, flickering around while the computers adjusted their course projections.

“The Horde frigates - they weren’t the vanguard!” Jack muttered as the icons stabilised. “They’re about to hit our rear!”

Just as the Ha’taks of the main body of Ba’al’s fleet dropped out of hyperspace in a close formation, so did the Horde frigates - spread out all around the planet, some far too close to the Alliance units, others far from any target.

In front of Jack, the squadrons of the task force shifted around, reacting to enemies in their rear, repositioning instead of hitting the Ha’taks and their escorts as hard as possible while they were still forming up after leaving hyperspace.

One Ha’tak that had come out a bit too far away from the rest was ganged up by four frigates and blew up before it could return fire, two more got disabled by a squadron darting forward and strafing them, but the main body was moving into a tight formation.

Jack clenched his teeth. Why wasn’t Carter using their super-jammer? Ba’al’s Horde frigates were already starting hit-and-run attacks - one of them was going after the troop transports! And the Goa’uld ships were closing in with each other, Jack almost expected their shields to overlap. They would be able to support each other by the dozens, and that… Oh.

The entire projection flickered for a moment, icons shifting colours to indicate loss of real-time sensor data.

“Jamming field active.”

The ship icons started to flicker around as the magitech sensors started to feed them data - not quite as effective as a full sensor fusion, but effective enough to get the picture.

And it was a better picture now. Jack could see the Goa’uld formation starting to fray as the suddenly blinded ships tried to avoid colliding with each other. One Al’kesh icon blinked and went out after crashing into a Ha’tak. Which had tried to evade at the

last moment and crashed into another Ha'tak, leaving both ships spinning, obviously damaged.

And Ba'al's Horde ships were caught in it as well - Jack saw them veering off. Couldn't continue with an attack run if you were suddenly blinded! The one going after the troop transports was suddenly off-course when the transports moved and it couldn't compensate - and was caught between the transports and the squadron coming for it. Outnumbered six to one, it tried to escape but flew directly into the focused fire of two frigates without any attempt to evade it. "And that's all she wrote," Jack mumbled as the icon disappeared.

The other frigates didn't fare much better - one was retreating, trailing parts and debris, chased by three Alliance ships, two more were flying so evasively, even Jack could see that their fire wouldn't hit anything except through blind luck - and you needed focused fire to take down shields. And two were… entering the planet's atmosphere?

They were coming in at high speed - the thermal bloom from their entry would probably shine brighter than the sun - and the friction alone would strain their shields to the breaking point.

But none of the Alliance ships were in a position to fire at them. And so the frigates could loop around the planet and bleed off their speed and… Jack didn't need the computer projections to know where the two would end up.

Right above the base.

Or right in the base if they crashed.

Fuck.

*****

Orbit Above PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 23rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Supreme Commander, we have a report from the ships engaging the main body of the enemy. The Ha’taks have upgraded weapons. Standard Horde beam cannons.”

Adora had already seen the data. She stared at the holoprojection displaying the battle in the centre of the flagship’s bridge. The Hat’aks were still in disarray, their formation torn up as a result of the jamming and their blind response to the coordinated attacks by the Alliance task force. But they were trying to reform.

“Found another potential flagship,” Catra said next to her, tipping at one icon with her claw. “They’re in the centre of their piece of the fleet.” She marked it as a priority target, and Adora saw a squadron of Horde frigates make a high-speed pass that left the Ha’tak trailing debris as it drifted out of formation.

Adora would have preferred to let the enemy form up so they could identify the flagship and other ships carrying leaders by their comm traffic before jamming the entire system, but the Ba’al’s spoiling attack with his Horde frigates had forced her to suppress sensors and comms right away. Even so, the Alliance’s attacks were not nearly as effective as projected - not with half their forces dealing with the remaining frigates behind their lines. And the Ha’taks were proving to be tougher to crack as well - their shields were still standard Goa’uld ones, but they had improved firepower, which meant the Alliance ships couldn’t just weather their fire while destroying them.

“The battle is far too even for my taste,” Catra mumbled.

Adora was forced to agree. “At least the enemy frigates will be destroyed soon, and then we can shift our entire strength…” She broke off when she noticed two enemy frigates diving into the atmosphere. “What are they doing?”

“Trying to skip off the planet’s atmosphere to get away from pursuit? No, the angle’s all wrong…” Catra cursed. “They’re swinging around the planet to attack the base! Or crash into it!”

Adora gasped. “We have to stop them!”

But their frigates were out of position, having tried to block an escape attempt that never happened, and… “What are the transports doing?” she asked even though she already knew the answer - they were dropping into the atmosphere as well. And they were the only ships close enough to cover the base.

“Fleet transports can’t shoot it out with frigates,” Catra hissed. “Not for long.”

But maybe long enough for the squadrons chasing the enemy frigates to arrive. Which meant Adora couldn’t order the transports to back off.

“Signal from HMS Albion, with Captain Baker’s compliments, Supreme Commander: ‘The Navy must not let the Army down.’”

Adora agreed. She still felt terrible watching the two transports form up to cover the base against the two frigates. They didn’t even have the improved beam cannons most frigates sported.

“Here they come!” Catra said.

The two frigates were finishing their swing around the planet and entering the line of sight - and lines of fire - of HMS Albion and HMS Bulwark. Beam weapons fired a moment later. Or had already fired - the holoprojection lagged a bit because of the jamming field.

Adora checked the rest of the battle - the other frigates had been killed, and the squadrons were rushing towards the main line, where the Goa’uld forces had split into two looser formations; not quite able to cover each other and barely able to cover individual ships, but still more effective than the ragged mass of confused movement they had been before.

Then, she focused on the base battle again. The frigates had broken to the left, trying to get around the transports so they had a free line of fire to the base. Captain Baker was manoeuvring to

block them, though it was costing him - each time the status data was refreshed, it showed more damage on both transports.

But relief was on the way. A squadron was entering the atmosphere. They just had to hold out a little longer…

The icon of HMS Bulwark flashed red, and Adora gasped again.

"It's gonna crash!" Catra spat.

"Signal from HMS Bulwark, Supreme Commander: They have to conduct an emergency landing."

Escape pods would barely launch at this altitude… Still, Adora saw a few appear on the holoprojection as HMS Bulwark dropped further down, barely able to pull the nose up at the last moment so the ship didn't bury itself straight into the ground but ploughed through the fields until it came to a stop. But it didn't explode!

And before the two frigates could focus on HMS Albion - or split up and bombard the base - the frigate squadron arrived, improved beam cannons blazing. The first frigate was caught trying to get around the transport and blew up in the air, pieces scattering across the fields below. The second had been exchanging fire with the transport while dragging it away and suddenly turned towards it - but the attempt came too late, and it too blew up before it could get close.

The base was safe, and Adora sighed with relief.

But the same couldn't be said for the fleet. With their beam cannons, the Ha'tak could keep the frigates somewhat at bay, and there were a lot of Ha'taks compared to Alliance frigates, so the Clones couldn't just trade broadsides and focus on individual Goa'uld ships to quickly take them out. And their fighters were outnumbered by Tel'taks and Death Gliders as well. They had to take risks and try for fly-by attacks, and with the jamming field active, those were not as effective as they could be.

The fight was far from won.

*****

In the frigate carrying their jamming gear, Samantha Carter stared at the holoprojection in front of her. It wasn't as large as the one on the bridge, but it was more than sufficient to follow the battle fought around them. Especially one part of it. The one in the planet's atmosphere.

"Those were the last Horde frigates Ba'al had," she commented, trying not to show her relief when she saw the second of them explode. The General was safe. "That leaves his upgraded Ha'taks."

She checked the jamming field as the holoprojection's focus switched. The field was stable, the adaptive routines that kept it so were still performing according to expectations. It would keep preventing enemy communications, but only to a point - they couldn't keep it up too long, or the same energy fields that served to jam enemy communications and sensors would tear it apart. Compensating manually would only delay that since they were already running it at full power; any more, and it would burn out the emitters. About fifteen, maybe twenty more minutes. Thirty, tops, if she and Entrapta spent the time adjusting the routines and intervals by hand, but ultimately, they would have to turn it off. At least they could still jam communications and sensors with conventional means, but those were even more limited.

"Shouldn't they retreat now?" Entrapta asked.

Sam looked at the battle in progress. If Ba'al wanted to save his fleet, then retreating now was the best option - his frigates had been destroyed, and the frigates which had been dispatched for that were heading back to rejoin the rest of the task force fighting the main part of Ba'al's fleet. Despite the upgrades, the Ha'taks were still no match for Horde ships, and the Al'kesh and Tel'taks hadn't received any upgrades at all, as far as they could tell. Despite their numerical superiority, they could barely hold the line against the current number of Horde frigates fighting them and were steadily losing ships at the edges of their formations.

“Yes, they should,” Sam said. “If Ba’al wants to preserve this fleet.”

Sam watched as a Ha’tak got separated from the rest of the formation, and four frigates darted forward, beam cannons flashing, as soon as the enemy ship left the protective umbrella provided by the massed fire of the other capital ships. With their sensors blinded and their communications disrupted, the ship’s crew must have failed to notice the shifting course of the main formation. And with four frigates focusing on the Ha’tak - even though they were doing so in a high-speed pass that reduced the volume of fire they could bring to bear, especially with their own sensors degraded by the jamming - the enemy shields collapsed, followed by the hull being holed seconds later. The ship blew up as the frigates sped away.

“But without working communications, their commander cannot order them to retreat,” Sam went on. “And if individual ships start to retreat, their entire formation collapses.” And the Alliance frigates - even without the reinforcements joining them now - would make short work of the enemy ships that kept fighting - or were just too slow to retreat as well. As long as the jamming field was active, the fleet couldn’t retreat in a coordinated manner - they could only rout. But staying meant they would be attrited by constant attacks exploiting holes in their formations. “Damned if they do, damned if they don’t,” she whispered. The enemy’s only chance was to outlast the jamming field until communications were restored.

And the Alliance had to make the most of their advantage until then so they could minimise their own casualties.

Two squadrons took off from the battle line and started a flanking manoeuvre. Usually, such a move would be countered at once - but the enemy was still blinded. Two Tel’taks and one Al’kesh spotted them by chance and tried to block them, but against a dozen frigates, they stood no chance. All three were blown up without the two squadrons slowing down on their way to pounce on the anchor of the enemy formation, four Ha’taks flying in close

formation surrounded by a dozen Al'keshs and Tel'taks and countless Death Gliders.

Sam adjusted the routines again, compensating for a modulating interference, while she watched the uneven fight. Outnumbered three to one, the outcome was a foregone conclusion. The smaller craft didn't matter; with their sensors jammed, the Tel'taks were struggling against Horde fighters and the Al'keshs were built to bomb planets and slow capital ships, not fast frigates.

But even so, the enemies sold their lives dearly; Sam saw damage reports light up from one frigate before all four Ha'taks were destroyed. "They must have been able to coordinate their fire," she muttered. "Either standing orders or…" She checked the jamming field again and then their sensor data. "They have managed to switch to short-range radio communications. Their command network will soon be restored." At least partially.

"I'm adjusting the routines again," Entrapta replied. "Done!"

That bought them a bit more time. Three more Ha'taks were destroyed and two left crippled in exchange for another damaged frigate while Sam made more manual adjustments. The Alliance fleet was switching to high-speed passes again as the enemy fire grew more focused. That would slow down the rate of attrition but also reduce the damage taken.

More Ha'taks were destroyed or damaged in the following minutes, but the enemy coordination grew from individual ships and their escorts to small formations, and the alliance ships took more and more damage. By the time the entire enemy fleet had restored their communication network, the Alliance units had drawn back.

But against Sam's expectations, the remaining Goa'uld ships didn't begin to retreat. They formed up into a wedge formation instead - as if they intended to press their attack.

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PT-9521-System, June 20th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"They're not retreating. They've lost half their forces, including all their Horde frigates, and they're attacking instead."

Catra nodded at Adora's comment but didn't take her eyes off the holographic display of the battle. Ba'al's forces were indeed pressing the attack, seemingly heedless of the losses they had taken and were still taking. And even though the enemy fleet had restored its communication network, Catra couldn't see any sign of a more complicated attack formation - they had just formed a wedge, well, a cone, the most basic attack formations, and started to move, apparently trying to reach the planet behind the Alliance lines.

"They might have orders to fight until they win or die," she said. It would fit how the Jaffa had behaved when defending the base on the planet - few had surrendered. But those were mostly infantry. Would Ba'al waste capital ships - upgraded capital ships - with trained crews like that? Did he have so many ships available that even wasting this fleet would see him come out ahead as long as they managed to damage the Alliance forces here? But if he had that many ships, why wouldn't he have sent more ships to begin with? That would have reduced his casualties.

And if he was planning to attrite the task force, he needed to do better; the enemy ship's Horde beam cannons hit significantly harder than the standard Goa'uld arsenal, but so far, the Alliance hadn't outright lost many frigates; most of the ships who had taken significant damage had managed to disengage under the cover of the rest of the fleet and withdraw.

Although with the enemy being able to coordinate better, that kind of manoeuvre became harder for the Alliance forces. Especially since the Alliance forces couldn't use high-speed passes to pick out individual targets as easily as before - they couldn't just retreat as far as they wanted until their shields had restored their strengths; they had to block the enemy from reaching the planet or the base would be bombarded from orbit. That drastically

limited their tactical options, which meant more frigates getting damaged.

Or getting destroyed, she added silently when she saw an icon in the blocking force disappearing in an explosion. She checked the data from the forces involved and winced - the frigates were steadily receiving damage despite their manoeuvering, and more and more Alliance ships were forced to rotate back in without having fully restored their shields.

Sure, the Goa'uld ships were paying a heavy toll - they were too slow to rotate in and out of the line, so their numbers were shrinking even more - but they had had more to begin with, and while Catra could already tell that the snakes would lose, the casualties this would cost the force would be severe unless they either abandoned the defence of the planet so they could use their speed to dictate the engagement again or found a way to break the enemy. Taking out their flagship hadn't fazed them; they had just kept pushing.

"Envelop them?" she asked. It would turn the battle into an even bloodier close-quarters fight, something that negated the advantages of the Alliance forces, but it might disrupt the enemy formation enough to break it up. As soon as the Goa'uld fleet lost their cohesion, the Horde frigates could pick them apart piecemeal. But the losses…

"We don't have any squadrons fresh enough to survive plunging into the enemy's rear if they don't break right away," Adora said. "And most of our fighters are busy with the Death Gliders and Al'keshs trying to reach the planet, so we can't send them in first to spoil their response."

"Yeah". Catra clenched her teeth. There had to be something they could do to stop this battle from turning into a meat grinder, but she couldn't think of one. The jamming field wasn't affecting the radio network, and up close, the conventional jamming wouldn't be able to overpower the enemy's radio either.

“We’ve identified another enemy command vessel, Supreme Commander!”

Catra saw the icon on the display change colours. A natural target - but it was in the centre of the enemy formation. Taking it out would cost the Alliance. And it didn’t seem as if the enemy needed new orders - they were just pushing ahead.

“Ignore it,” Adora said. She must have come to the same conclusion. “Focus on the most vulnerable enemy ships.”

“Yes, Supreme Commander.”

But the number of frigates that weren’t combat-ready any more and had to retreat from the battle kept growing - and the Alliance reserves were all damaged by now; if they had to be used in an emergency, they wouldn’t last long.

“The enemy sensors are still affected by the jamming field. If we could mask our damaged frigates, make them look like fresh reinforcements, and send them into the enemy rear, they might mistake them for another task force,” Catra said. “But if the enemy is determined to fight to the last anyway…”

Adora nodded. “It wouldn’t work.”

“Well, then I’ve got a last gamble,” Catra said. “Withdraw the blocking force. Let them regenerate their shields and then hit the enemy right when they are about to hit the base and are distracted.”

“That would risk the base.”

“Yes.” Catra nodded. “But it would save more of our frigates.” And their experienced crews. Hell of a risk, though - if the timing was a little bit off…

“It’s our best bet.” Adora pressed her lips together, then gave the orders. “Warn the base that there might be orbital strikes that get through.”

On the screen, the frigates in the blocking force suddenly sped up, evasive manoeuvres turning into full withdrawals at high speed. The squadrons on the enemy flanks kept their strafing attacks up for a bit longer, to give the centre more cover to retreat before falling back as well so they wouldn't be facing the brunt of the enemy's firepower.

The enemy fleet didn't quite falter, but Catra could see a sort of ripple, individual ships seeming to hesitate before continuing their course toward the planet as the frigates withdrew out of the Goa'uld's reduced sensor ranges. She kept an eye on the data feed from the ships, watching their shield strengths regenerate, comparing it to the shrinking distance between the enemy van and the orbit. "Too damn close." Only a few would have their shields restored fully in time.

"It's our best bet," Adora repeated herself.

That didn't make it a good idea. But this was war - sometimes, you didn't have any good idea.

The distance kept shrinking. Soon, the fighters still keeping the smaller enemy crafts at bay would be in range of the Ha'taks' batteries. And then the base below.

"Jamming field at emergency strength, Supreme Commander."

That meant the enemy sensors would be almost blinded - but it wouldn't last long before the projectors burnt out.

"All units, resume the attack!" Adora ordered.

The frigates, already in position, partially shielded by the planet itself, accelerated and flew against the enemy formation. The timing was almost perfect - they entered conventional sensor range right before the enemy came into range of the base. Half the enemy ships were already focused on getting into positions needed for orbital bombardment, the other half still pushing forward.

Catra smiled when she saw the enemy formation fall apart in the most crucial moment - right before the Alliance squadrons hit them in a coordinated strike.

The enemy command ship was among the first to blow up.

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Ba’al’s Machinations Part 5

Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 23rd, 2000 (Earth Time)

The plan - or desperate gamble - had worked! Jack O’Neill bared his teeth in a grin while he watched the snake fleet get torn up in orbit. Their formation had dissolved into isolated, uncoordinated small groups and even individual ships, and the Alliance frigates were tearing them apart.

A number of Death Gliders and a handful of cloaked Tel’taks had already entered the atmosphere, but they were tangling with Alliance fighters at high altitude, and Jack didn’t give them good odds to get into range of the base, much less damage it. On the contrary, trying to reach the base made them easy prey for the fighters - he saw one Tel’tak get shot down from behind by a pair of fighters as it tried to make a run for their target.

“I guess after this, they must realise that we can see through their cloaks,” he commented. That would affect their strategic situation, but it had been inevitable - they couldn’t actually let cloaked enemy ships do whatever they wanted just to keep their sensor advantage a secret. Of course, some intel-weenie had actually suggested doing that, but the sane members of the Command Council had shot him down. This wasn’t ULTRA, and even if it were, the Etherians would never let attacks on soldiers, much less civilians, go through just to keep a secret.

Jack approved of the stance. What good was an advantage if you didn’t use it? If you wanted to save it for the best time, you probably wouldn’t use it before it was no longer useful one way or the other.

“Sir! The central part of the enemy fleet…”

But Jack had already spotted it. Four Ha’taks had managed to survive two fly-by attack runs and were about to enter the

atmosphere - and not, like almost all other snake ships, by breaking up and scattering themselves as one huge meteor shower, but in close formation.

Very close - three of the ships were shielding the fourth with their hulls. That was crazy! One of them broke up under the attack by a squadron of frigates that had hastily changed targets. Another collided with the central Ha'ak and was thrown off-course, plasma forming a fireball around it as it spun out of control - and then vanished in a brighter fireball.

That left two on a straight course for the base. Someone behind Jack gasped.

Damn. Jack scoffed, loudly. "They already tried that, and it didn't work with frigates. Those are Ha'taks and not nearly as tough!" Not entirely correct, of course - frigates were much smaller, and while they had stronger shields and better armour, but once both were gone, a Ha'tak would be able to absorb more damage before it broke up.

More, but not as much as the Alliance ships were dishing out. Jack grinned again when five frigates focused their fire from behind. The last escorting ship shielding the main ship blew up after a second of focused fire tore through her shields.

And then it was the main ship's turn. Beam cannons flashed, and the Ha'tak's shields broke - and it was still out of range of the base.

And then it blew up. Jack started to sigh with relief under his breath - but then the computer started screaming alerts.

"Atmospheric explosion detected."

"Shockwave detected."

"Thermal bloom at lethal levels."

On the holoprojection, the ship had vanished in a huge fireball - so massive, the pursuing frigates had been touched by it as well, and Jack saw their status displays go red at once, followed by at least one 'abandon ship' notice.

But that wasn't the worst. The worst was seeing the fireball engulf part of the planet's atmosphere - and the shockwave running forward.

And hearing the screams outside - the camera feed from the base's perimeter showed the sky on fire!

Jack pushed the general alert button and yelled: "Everyone, take cover! Shockwave about to hit the base! Take cover! Run to shelter! Duck and cov…!"

The entire base shook as if an earthquake had hit, cutting him off - he almost fell to the floor.

And more alerts sounded. The screens were flashing red with notices. Damage detected, thermal energy dissipation - what the hell was that? Sensors and structural integrity damaged, incoming environmental dangers…

He gripped the edge of the table and stared at the screen showing the base outside. The sky was on fire, winds stronger than the worst hurricane he had ever seen were battering the buildings, ash was raining down, though he had no idea where that came from...

It looked like a sandstorm in Hell.

And would be about as lethal. Jack cursed again and started yelling orders - he had people and a base to save, and no time to do it.

*****

Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 24th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Adora pointed her sword at her target and focused her power one more time. As before, magic poured out in a beam and washed over the man standing in front of her, healing him of everything that was wrong. Or whatever.

She closed her eyes while the man gasped, patting himself down. That was… She had lost count of how many she had healed. Alliance soldiers, freed slaves, prisoners of war who hadn't been moved yet…

"I am… the pain is gone! Praise to the Goddess!"

Right. "I just healed you," she told him. "It's not… it's just magic."

"As they said! You are the light of the people! The Bringer of Hope!"

Those were new titles. Had Priest expanded his list, or were those names the people here had come up with? She didn't know, and she didn't want to ask.

And now the man was bowing - no, falling to his knees and pushing his forehead against the floor.

Adora suppressed a groan and nodded at the two … nurses or orderlies, she didn't remember what function they had after they had rotated a few times, and the two stepped up and gently guided the praying man out of the room.

"Was that the last?" Adora asked.

"Yes, Supreme Commander."

"Good."

She closed her eyes again and sat down in the chair in the corner. She was so tired!

"You know, you could have saved yourself hours of effort if you had waited until we'd have scanned everyone to check if your

healing was actually needed."

Adora opened her eyes just enough to focus on Catra, who was leaning against the doorframe and replied: "I wasn't about to wait and risk people suffering - or even dying - before we figure out what happened."

"And that's why people worship you." Catra flashed her fangs in a grin, but the effect was lost somewhat when it turned into a yawn.

"And you spent hours sorting out the fleet," Adora shot back, "instead of leaving that to the commanders and captains."

"Hey! It was my plan that caused the mess, so I fixed it as well." Catra shrugged. "Those are the rules."

"Those aren't the rules." Adora shook her head. "The rules actually are that officers should get enough rest whenever possible so they aren't exhausted when they are needed. Tired people make bad decisions!"

"Exactly!"

"Don't… what?" Adora blinked and opened her eyes a bit more. Catra's wide grin showed all her teeth as if she had just won a contest or something.

"Those are the rules, and since you're the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, you need to get rest as soon as possible."

"Oh, you…!" Adora groaned. "Now that people are healed I have to…"

"...go to sleep," Catra finished for her. "Those are your own standing orders."

Which were broken every time it was necessary, but… "Those orders cover you as well!" Adora shot back.

“No.” Catra grinned again. “I’m no Alliance officer. No commission. No salary. No orders.”

Adora scoffed as she got up.

“So, now be a good little Supreme Commander and… Hey!”

Adora grabbed her and threw her over her shoulder.

“Leggo!”

Adora ignored her. “Now, where’s our bed?”

Catra growled, but after a moment, she relented and Adora felt her relax and basically hang over her shoulder like a bag of wet sand.

“Yes?”

“I commandeered the former base commander’s personal quarters,” Catra said.

“And you claim you’re not an officer in the Alliance!” Adora snorted and started walking.

“I’m not!”

“And what about the actual base commander?” Adora asked after they had left the room. “Did you tell him to leave his own room?”

“He never moved into the quarters,” Catra said. “Claimed they were too luxurious.”

“Oh.” Adora almost stopped. “Is it bad?”

“No worse than Bright Moon’s palace, just with gold instead of pastel.”

That was pretty bad, but Adora really was exhausted. And she was sure that Catra needed the rest as well. A few hours wouldn’t hurt, would they? She stifled a yawn. No, they wouldn’t.

They put their masks on - the air was still filled with dust and ash - and left the hospital building. It looked a bit battered - it had been built from pre-fab components carried by the Fleet transports, fortunately, before HMS Bulwark had crash-landed. The sky was still, not glowing, but far more reddish than normal, especially since it was past midnight here, something about dust particles and thermal energy dissipation that Adora hadn't quite understood when Sam had explained.

Whatever. Adora was walking towards the main administrative building when a cloud of sparkles appeared next to her.

"Adora! Have you finish… what are you doing?"

Adora smiled at Glimmer. "We're going to bed."

For some reason, her friend blinked, then blushed. "Really?"

"Catra insisted. And I think we both need this." Adora shrugged, which made Catra gasp in reaction to the movement. "She commandeered the base commander's quarters for us."

"Ah… OK…" Glimmer was still blushing.

But she had been looking for Adora, hadn't she? "Did anything happen? Do you need me?" Adora asked.

"Ah… No, no, I just wanted to check up on you, see if you've finished healing everyone." Glimmer said. "And tell you that Frosta and Perfuma have arrived through the Stargate on the flagship and will work on restoring the planet's ecosystem and atmosphere as soon as possible."

"Good. They can check with Entrapta and Sam about where they should use their powers first." Adora nodded. Their friends had made plans already, but she hadn't paid attention to the details. Something about filtering plants and lots of ice to melt to replace the vaporised water or something - Adora trusted her friends to do this. "No, sorry, but our bed is calling."

“Yeah, sure…”

Glimmer was still flushed, Adora noticed. “Are you sick? I can heal you if you are…”

“No, no, everything’s fine. See you tomorrow! Have fun!” Glimmer disappeared with a slight pop.

Catra started to giggle and, despite Adora asking repeatedly, refused to tell her what was so funny.

*****

Samantha Carter stifled a yawn when she stepped up to the screen in the briefing room. It had been a long day and a short night. But then, everyone had been burning the midnight oil, so she wasn't the only one running on a few hours of sleep and lots of coffee.

Although Adora and Catra looked far more awake than they should be if they had been doing what the rumour mill on base claimed. And Teal'c was… Teal'c. He probably could sleep while standing at attention.

But Sam had a briefing to conduct. And data to show.

She touched the screen, and it lit up with her prepared displays. She glanced at the General, but he didn’t joke about PowerPoint being a war crime, and so she started her briefing. “Based on the analysis we ran on all the sensor data, the explosion was caused by a Naquadah-enhanced warhead. If the bomb had hit the base - which was the intended target based on the course the ship had taken - it would have been completely destroyed.” And all people on it would have died. The small simulation running on the screen next to her showed that.

“Yeah, I think we got that already since it almost destroyed the world.” The General bared his teeth in a shadow of a grin.

He was joking, but not as much as he probably thought he was. “The bomb, or, more precisely, the knock-on effects of its explosion, came close to destroying the planet's ecology,” she told him, noticing how his eyes opened wider at that. She changed the display on the screen, showing the planet and then the explosion. “Without intervention by the Alliance, the various ecosystems of this world would not recover and likely be unable to adjust to the devastation, affecting other areas. The direct and indirect effects of the thermal energy and radiation released into the planet alone would be enough to cause a catastrophic disruption of the life cycles of most of the fauna. The complete collapse of the planet's biosphere would have been unlikely, but only because certain primitive plants would have survived.”

Everyone was staring at her even though that shouldn't have been news to most of them - that was why they had called in Frosta and Perfuma. But even those two looked shocked.

Yes, everyone was still too tired, in Sam's opinion.

“If they had launched that thing from their ships…” Glimmer trailed off.

“Between the sensor jamming, the fighters in the atmosphere and the pursuing frigates, the odds of any missile large enough to carry the enhanced warhead reaching the base would have been low,” Bow said. “That was probably why they tried to force their way to the base, or close enough.”

Sam nodded in agreement. The Ha'tak had been on an end run when the bomb had blown up. Whether that had been due to battle damage or because the ship's commander had realised they wouldn't reach firing range and decided to detonate the bomb anyway, they probably would never know.

“So, your jamming field saved the base,” the General said, smiling at her. “Good work, Carter, Entrapta.”

Sam felt pleased but hid it. She had just done her duty, she reminded herself - as had all the others who had fought in the battle. “Efforts to stabilise the ecosystems and deal with the lingering effects of the explosion are ongoing, but preliminary analysis is positive,” she went on, nodding at Frosta and Perfuma. “However, the process, while self-sustaining, will take months to years to finish.” At which point the filter plants were supposed to die off without the pollution they required. It had worked in the former Fright Zone, but this was the first time they were used on a global scale.

“Good.” Adora smiled for a moment. “But we need better defences - if Ba'al is willing to destroy worlds, we have to be prepared.”

Sam and Entrapta had some ideas about that. Planetary shields. Missile defence systems. Directed sensor jamming fields that didn't disable the FTL communications and targeting sensors on the world they defended. They all would require massive investments, but data and footage from this battle would likely convince the Alliance leaders to adjust their budgets. If the Goa'uld used such bombs against Earth or Etheria… She shuddered at the thought.

“Adora's healing has taken care of the effects of the radiation, and our filters and masks are more than able to deal with the lingering pollution, so there's no long-term danger to the health of the garrison and staff,” Sam continued. “Incidentally, all the wounded who were not evacuated to the hospital ships are back on duty now.”

“Did I miss someone?” Adora spoke up.

“All serious wounds were dealt with,” Glimmer told her.

Sam nodded and took a step to the side, letting Entrapta take over.

“Now, salvage!” Her friend beamed. “We've got lots of ships and ships’ parts to recover! And a lot of ships to repair, so we can use

some parts we salvage for repairs. Not too many, though, since they only had like half a dozen Horde frigates." Data appeared on the screen as her hair moved over the controls. "Fortunately, reinforcements will bring the fleet train with them, so we should have most damaged frigates at least partially repaired in a few weeks. But! Full repairs will take months at the currently projected rate." Entrapta pouted. "We just don't have the repair capacity available in this area to handle everything at once - and sending the ships back to the main logistics hubs would take as long. We should build up more repair capacities, but that would reduce our short-term repair capacities. But it would help in the long run!"

It was a sensible plan - the Alliance needed to massively increase their production capacity to win this war - but they didn't know if Ba'al would let them or if they needed the fleet units here repaired as fast as possible to defend against his next attack - and defeat him. They desperately needed more intel.

"So… almost all the ships we can salvage are in space. Because those who crashed on the planet aren't salvageable any more. Except this one!" Entrapta gestured, and a picture of the crash-landed HMS Bulwark appeared on the screen. It was half-buried in a small hill. More data appeared next to the picture, listing the damages.

Sam winced even though she had seen the data before.

"As you can see, she needs new engines - if her engines had been intact she wouldn't have crashed, though the engines were intact enough to let her crash-landed instead of crashing completely - and a lot of other stuff, but the engines are the main thing. And we can't use the yardships until we get her up to space, though that shouldn't be a problem once we have a squadron to coordinate their tractor beams and made sure that the hull's vacuum-proof again. Which is kind of a problem, but everyone should be wearing a vacuum suit anyway for safety reasons. Like in a lab. And we need to…"

As Entrapta went into the details of salvage, Sam stifled another yawn. She needed more coffee, but the General, who looked like he was just one soft chair away from falling asleep as well, was eyeing her with that familiar look that told her she would be ordered to rest after this.

Well, she did need the sleep, and things were under control. For now, at least.

*****

Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 25th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Alright, everyone and everything's clear - lift'er up!"

"Commencing operation."

Catra watched as the massive hull of HMS Bulwark was lit up by six tractor beams and seemed to tremble just a bit.

"Synchronising the beams."

"Beams Synchronised. Variables within tolerances."

"Starting to lift."

As the Clone kept reporting, the transport slowly started to rise from where she had buried herself into half a hill. The vast majority of the earth and rock that had been covering her bow had been removed before this operation, which had delayed the salvage, but even so, streams of dirt and smaller rocks rained down on all sides of the ship, forming streams in some sports, as it slowly rose higher and higher. Catra saw larger rocks and entire boulders tumble through the air, one bouncing off the hull twice before hitting the ground. Well, the hull was holed multiple times anyway.

But the fleet transport kept rising, tethered to the six frigates arrayed above her by tractor beams. Soon, she was far above the

ground, lit up by the sun.

Still, getting the transport off the ground was the easy part, as Catra knew. Getting it into orbit would be tricky. That required far more fine control than merely lifting it up.

"Closing in."

The six frigates slowly approached the transport, closing the distance until they were less than a hundred metres away on all four sides, with two on top.

"If that works out, they should start an air acrobatic team," Jack commented next to her.

"Do you doubt Sam and Entrapta's calculations?" Catra asked without taking her eyes away from the floating ships above them.

"No. But I don't doubt that some piloting mistake could still mess things up."

That was true. But it would have to be a truly huge mistake - or deliberate sabotage - with all the computers controlling things and the close overwatch and coordination from the lead ship of the squadron. Then again, Catra had seen such mistakes in the Horde. And not just from Kyle. "We'll see," she said.

"Initiating second phase."

Catra saw the engines light up before her ears picked up the growing noise from them, and then all seven ships started to accelerate.

"Target velocity reached."

"On Course."

Catra shrugged as the ships shrank until they were just a speck in the sky. "Looks like it worked."

“All that for a proof of concept,” Jack said. “Could have just waited for the yardship to arrive in the system and pick her up.”

They could have. But they had limited numbers of repair ships, and picking up a fleet transport from the ground would have still required the help of a few frigates - yardships were meant to recover ships in space. And it was good to know that they could recover ships with synchronised tractor beams; that kind of capability could come in handy in the war. “I guess the squadron will be nicknamed the Heavy Lifters or something like it,” Catra said.

“Probably. The Clones don't really get that call signs are supposed to be something to rib people about.” Jack frowned in a slightly pouty way.

“It's not a call sign. It's a unit nickname,” Catra corrected him. “Those are supposed to raise morale.”

“The Clones are too serious; a bit of humour would help them more.”

Of course, Jack would think that. “They have a sense of humour. It's just a bit subtle compared to what other people I know think is funny,” Catra shot back.

“Hey!” Jack mock-frowned at her, then sighed. “Well, that's over with. Time to get back to paperwork.”

Catra shrugged again. “Good luck. I'll check out the terra-reforming efforts.”

Before Jack could complain about her skipping paperwork, they saw another frigate appear in the sky. No, not a frigate - that was HMS Albion, the second fleet transport. “That must be the salvaged shield generators,” Catra said. “Someone got lucky up there.” Or unlucky - often, the shield generators didn't survive when a ship went down, but sometimes, a ship was wrecked after the shields were overloaded and shattered, with the shield generators themselves still intact.

“Won't stop a superbomb,” Jack muttered. “The shockwave in the atmosphere makes it too strong.”

“But it will protect the base against a closer miss,” Catra pointed out.

Jack shrugged. “Might probably be more effective if we used the thing on one more ship.”

Catra agreed, but leaving the base entirely unprotected was unacceptable.

“And I can already hear the howling back home on Earth. Everyone will want planetary shields and huge anti-orbital guns and everything else they think will stop such an attack.”

“That's what the fleet is for,” Catra commented. One enhanced warhead, ten normal warheads… if you destroyed the ship carrying them before it could fire them, it wouldn't matter what had been carried.

“Won't make people feel as safe as having a huge shield protecting the world,” Jack said. “We'll spend the money.”

“Do you think that was Ba'al's plan? Make us cut back on building ships in favour of building massive shields?” Catra asked.

“Might have been part of his plan,” Jack said. “But there's probably more to it. The snake's smart.”

But they didn’t know how smart. And, more importantly, they didn't know how much Ba'al knew about the Alliance and how many forces he had at his disposal. Without more information, without solid intelligence, they could only speculate, and you couldn't really plan a war on that.

It was like swinging blindly in a dark room and hoping you took the other guy down before they knocked you out. If you had a staff and they didn't, if you were stronger, tougher, better

protected, than them, you had good chances. If the reverse was true… you better hope you got lucky.

Catra really wanted to know if she had to hope for a lucky punch (or plan a desperate gamble) or if she could be confident that they were likely to win as long as Ba'al didn't get lucky.

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Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 27th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Reinforcements had arrived. Finally. “Better late than never,” Jack O'Neill muttered as he watched the frigates fan out on the holographic display, relieving the various damaged but still serviceable ships on station.

More important was the arrival of Fourth Fleet's fleet train. Several yardships were already moving towards the Lagrange point, where the ships awaiting repairs were gathered, followed by the factory ships, which would supply them with the parts they needed.

And further out, mining ships covered by a couple of escorts were headed to the system's various asteroids to gather raw materials for the factory and refining ships.

HMS Bulwark was first in line for repairs - Jack had insisted on it. If Ba'al sent a bigger fleet and they had to evacuate the planet, they'd need her to get the troops off the planet. Sure, they could stuff the soldiers on the frigates, but that would mean leaving most of their gear, and that would come a bit too close to reenacting Dunkirk, in his opinion. The gear could be replaced - probably with more advanced stuff - but the hit to morale would remain for quite some time.

Besides, the fleet transport wasn't that much bigger than a frigate, and a single frigate wouldn't make much of a difference in a Fleet engagement. Not with the numbers present. To think that just a few years ago, two of Apophis's Ha'taks had been an overwhelming force which would have devastated Earth if not for

some luck and a lot of desperate action! Nowadays, the most concern the Alliance would have over an intrusion by two Ha'taks would be trying to make sense of such a move, whether it was a distraction or a mistake, or something even more convoluted.

Whatever. It seemed the Clones had things in hand in space.

Jack turned away from the display and went back to his desk to fight another battle with paperwork. Hell, once he was back on Earth, he had a few things to say about streamlining procedures for handling the wounded when magical healing was available. Those damned regulations were obviously not written with mass healing by She-Ra in mind! Or with attacks that potentially affected everyone on a planet. Someone must have been really concerned about wounded soldiers not getting their due if they were healed too quickly since, if he handled it by the book, they'd end up with a 100% casualty rate on report. Just because, technically, everyone had been dosed with the radiation from the enhanced snake bomb going off and then healed by Adora before they could find out if they were actually in need of the healing or not! Purple Hearts or whatever the limeys awarded for being wounded for everyone!

He couldn't even dump the whole thing on Adora as the Supreme Commander - Catra would find a way to deal with the paperwork, Jack was sure, if only to ensure her lover had some time free to spend with her for the next month or so - because he'd have to process all the reports anyway for that.

Well, at least he had an excuse to delay filing the paperwork 'until the current situation at the front allowed it'. It was a wonderfully vague term, and as the commander for the entire ground component of the operation, he got to define the situation as he wanted.

And he wanted it to be as dire as needed to bury the damn healing paperwork until he could dump it on the same people back on Earth who made the regulations that caused this mess.

He quickly saved all the medical reports in a special folder marked ‘not urgent, don't touch’ and focused on the reports that actually were critical. Unit readiness was good. Unlike the fleet in orbit, all of his troops were ready for action. Base defences were getting there. The shield generators were coming online - he made a mental note to check on Carter's sleeping schedule. They wouldn't be able to withstand whatever superbomb Ba'al had tried to use, but Death Gliders and Tel'taks would have a very hard time getting through those shields even if they came at it by the dozens. Unfortunately, they still didn't have anti-orbital defences and wouldn't get them in the foreseeable future unless Carter and the other science and technology people here took over a factory ship and built some big honking space guns or torpedos launchers.

Which was actually not that implausible, he realised as he thought about it. If he asked, they would probably do it. But should he ask? They had a lot of other critical tasks, and a factory ship building anti-orbital cannons wouldn't be building parts to repair the damaged ships…

He sighed. As much as he liked to give his soldiers the ability to shoot back at people trying to bomb them - who wouldn't? - having more ships doing that further away from the planet so they couldn't drop a superbomb on another part of the world would be more effective. So, no big honking anti-orbital guns for him.

And, speaking of damaging the entire planet… He checked the reports from the ‘restoration task force’ aka Frosta and Perfuma. He skipped all the magical and sciency details until he got to the summary. So, the dust in the air would remain for a bit longer - the filtering plants were spreading but hadn't reached the tip-off point yet - but the planet wouldn't dry out or flood in the near future.

In other words, the planet wouldn't die, but his troops would have to wear masks for a while longer. They would grumble about it, of course, but soldiers complained about everything. Even if he gave

every one of them a week's leave, they'd complain about not getting two weeks. Or not getting leave wherever they wanted.

He shook his head and started to go over the report from supplies.

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Orbit Above PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 26th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"Your Divine Highness! I mean, Supreme Commander!"

The Clone guard - from Fourth Fleet - had corrected himself, but Adora still narrowed her eyes at him. She was on duty, so she was to be addressed by her rank, not by any… religious title. She still returned the salute, of course, and entered the flag room on Fourth Fleet's flagship, which was now serving as a meeting room for the staff in the system.

"Hi, Adora!"

"Hi!"

"Good morning, Supreme Commander."

"Supreme Commander."

"Supreme Commander!"

She nodded at Glimmer and Bow, then at the other officers in the room, frowned at Jack's overeager greeting and smirk, and took her seat. "Catra's coming," she told them when she saw them eyeing the door. "She just wanted to wait for the results of her analysis."

"Analysis?" Glimmer blinked.

"Of our latest intel," Adora replied.

"Ah." Glimmer nodded. "Well, another opinion can't hurt."

That sounded a bit dismissive, Adora noted. Before she could say anything, though, Catra arrived. She strode inside as if she was on a catwalk - strutting - but Adora could tell from the way her hair was just a little messed and how her tail looked that she had been sprinting through the hallways on all fours to reach the room. But Catra's smirk also told her that she had found something.

"Hey!" Catra waved with one hand, the other holding a tablet, then sat down next to Adora.

Adora cleared her throat and stood. "Welcome, everyone. Now that Fourth Fleet's main force has joined us, we'll have to decide our future strategy. We've all read the status reports, so we know it'll be several weeks until all damaged ships will be ready for service, but we already have enough ships to cover the system and launch offensive operations." She ignored how Jack peered at his tablet; she knew he had read the reports since he had called her about some of the details beforehand and was just trying to annoy the British officers for one reason or another. "Unfortunately, we still haven't discovered a suitable target in the area. The prisoners we took didn't know the coordinates of any system serving as a base for Ba'al."

"We also confirmed that the navigators who knew such coordinates either took their own lives or were killed by Jaffa with special orders," Jack added with a grim expression.

Adora pressed her lips together. How sick did you have to be to give such orders? She took a deep breath. "But several of our spy bots are still out searching, our spy bot network is steadily expanding, and the Tok'ra are focusing on Ba'al's realm, so we expect this to change soon."

Judging by the expressions of the officers from Earth, they weren't very optimistic. The Clones though, both Fourth Fleet's provisional commander, Padre, and the commander of its fleet train, Wrench, were smiling, obviously trusting Adora's judgement completely.

She ignored the guilty feeling that caused inside her and nodded confidently. “So, opinions?”

The Captain of HMS Albion, Captain Baker, spoke up. “We’ve destroyed a major fleet of Ba’al and took few total losses. Even if this wasn’t the main part of his forces, he has to be reeling from the loss. We should capitalise on that and send smaller task forces into his territory to raid targets of opportunity to keep his forces off-balance and reacting to our raids.”

Catra spoke up before Adora could comment. That was a little unusual. “We’ve got an opportunity here. As we already know, Ba’al is running his realm as Horde Prime had been running his Empire - only he knows where everyone is and what their orders are. He deliberately keeps his forces divided and ignorant. That means that even though we are confident that he is reeling from losing a major force and has to be scrambling to replace his losses, his other forces won’t panic since they won’t be aware of this. However, that also means they won’t be able to coordinate their defences. So, we should mass our forces and overwhelm his bases and fleets piecemeal.”

“We don’t know the locations of his bases and fleets.” Captain Baker said. “And depending on how large his territory is, we might not be able to react in time to an opportunity unless we stage forces closer to and inside his territory.”

“If he concentrates his forces, then that gives us an opportunity to force a decisive battle on him,” Padre said. “If we can destroy his main fleet assets, we can raid his bases at our pleasure.”

“Someone has read the IJN’s handbook,” Jack muttered.

Padre nodded. “Indeed. And I believe that in our current situation, it’s an applicable strategy. The sooner we can destroy his forces, and with as much numerical superiority as possible, the better.”

“We still don’t know the extent of his forces,” Captain Baker pointed out.

“We don’t,” Catra said. “But we can’t wait until we do. As long as we can achieve local superiority, we can hurt him without suffering large casualties. And we cannot let him build up his forces.”

“That is why I think a spread-out force of small raiding forces would be best - they can strike at his bases whenever we find them and degrade his logistics and industrial assets.” Captain Baker wasn’t budging.

So, it seemed it was up to Adora to decide on what strategy they would take.

She pushed her chin up a little. “Until the majority of our ships are back in service, we won’t divide our forces and render them vulnerable to another massed attack,” she told them. “We should have more intel by that time, too.”

Captain Baker nodded, apparently accepting her decision. Good.

Now, they had to hope that one of their potential intel sources came through.

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PT-9521-System, June 28th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter didn't have to be present at the Lagrange point where most of the ship repairs of Fourth Fleet took place. She wasn't part of the fleet train, nor were routine repairs part of her duties. But between the yardships busy restoring the frigates which had been damaged in the battle and the factory ships churning out replacement shield generators, weapons and other spare parts, what salvage had been gathered from the enemy fleet floated, awaiting disposal. And while it would be easy to simply assign them to be dismantled and recycled, broken down to their components or even base materials and used for repairs and by the factory ships, the Alliance needed every shred of intel they could get - and you could gain a lot of data from a thorough analysis of an enemy ship. She could have supervised that from

her lab module with the frigate carrying it stationed anywhere in the system, but if she was on site, she could personally take a look if needed, and she liked that. Not that it had been needed so far.

“We should have done this sooner,” she commented while she supervised a bot taking samples from what was left of a Ha'tak. But there had been so much else to do.HMS Bulwark had to be salvaged, and none of the Clones had any experience with that kind of operation - the Horde simply wrote off any frigates that crashed on a planet. She had been tasked with designing anti-orbital weapons that could be hastily built and installed (and then ended up not built because priorities had shifted - Sam had had flashbacks to procurement on Earth. At least the General had apologised.) and the spy bots still attached to enemy ships had to be managed and checked on regularly so they didn't miss out on crucial intel, not to mention the mountain of other works piling up - literally, back on Earth, electronically here - on her desk.

“Yes!” Entrapta, of course, didn't disagree. “There's so much data to be had here! The material analysis of the hulls shows where they were built - well, not the coordinates, but we can tell which ships were built in the same yard based on the isotopes in the material.”

It was not a hundred per cent confirmed, of course - but the building techniques used by Ba'al's yards also showed differences that supported their assumptions. Unlike Earth’s new shipyards, Ba'al’s used a lot of customised work where individual labourers took the components delivered to the yard and then adapted them to fit into a particular ship. That had been a common way to get around insufficiently tight tolerances in production back on Earth as well and let them draw conclusions about Ba'al's resources. Well, that and the fact that they had captured one of his shipyards with its trained workforce, but any confirmation was useful.

Though that might change if Ba'al switched to Horde yardships and factory ships for production. He was using them, that was

certain, but was he able to build more of them and expand production? The fleet he had managed to recruit had limited resources, but if they could rely on Ba'al's slaves and mining bases, that would allow them to focus on building new yardships and factory ships, which would significantly speed up his arms programs. At least Sam's projections said so; there was still hope that there would be the usual friction and unforeseen complications delaying his programs.

“Oh! The analysis of all the beam weapons we recovered - and the parts we salvaged is done!” Entrapta announced.

“Ah.” Sam checked that there was no urgent task waiting for her, then joined her friend at the console in their lab module.

“Oh!” Entrapta almost cheered. “They are from the same factory, but we've got at least three different versions!”

Sam quickly checked the data herself. Entrapta was correct, not that Sam had doubted her. The beam cannons showed at least three different variations. “Standard Horde beam cannons, by and large, but there are also small numbers of simplified beam cannons. And here’s an even more reduced version.”

“Those are less powerful than standard beam cannons, though,” Entrapta said. “Did they work up to standard beam cannons?”

Sam switched windows. “All the data we have indicates that the beam cannons were produced by the same factory - or factory ship.”

“Hm.” Entrapta scrunched her nose as she thought. “And those would have had the designs for the standard beam cannon already. Why produce inferior variants, then?”

Sam grimaced. “Because the simpler versions will be able to be produced in greater numbers and with fewer resources. And they might be able to be produced by Ba'al's workers in new or refitted factories and yards.”

“Oh. That would mean he can get more of them to make up for their inferior performance…” Entrapta winced.

Sam nodded. Ba'al was upgrading his entire forces. They had to…

A beep from the main communication console interrupted her thoughts. That was a priority message - the spy bots!

She quickly changed the screens and took a look. A message burst from one spy bot attached to a Ha'tak's hull. Navigational data and pictures - days old, but apparently, the spy bot had just now gotten into range of the network.

She studied the pictures. That was a sizeable fleet - about the same numbers as the one they had defeated. Or even larger. And… “Are they building a space station?” she asked.

“...no.” Entrapta sounded uncharacteristically grimm, and Sam turned to look at her. “I recognise that part. They're building a flagship like the Velvet Glove.”

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Ba’al’s Machinations Part 6

Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 28th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“So, we’ve got a Death Star to destroy before it gets online. Anyone call Luke Skywalker?”

Catra snorted, once, at Jack’s joke. She had expected that joke ever since she had seen the pictures from the spy bot. It wasn’t that funny, though.

“Since the ship is still in the process of being built, this would be more like the second Death Star, and so I believe we should be calling Wedge Antilles and Lando Calrissian,” Teal’c said in a serious voice. Only the way his lips barely twisted upwards showed that he was joking as well.

But he was correct. “Yes, it’s more like the second Death Star. There are a few squadrons of frigates protecting it, together with a lot of Ha’taks and their escorts and a small army of Death Gliders,” Catra said. “And it looks like a trap as well.”

“A trap?” Captain Baker frowned. “What do you base this on?”

Mostly her gut feeling, but she couldn’t say that. Instead, Catra told him: “Ba’al concentrating all his efforts on a huge base ship? Instead of building multiple yardships and factory ships to expand his fleet train, spread out so if he loses one or two, it’s not going to be crippling his forces? That sounds fishy.”

“Are you honestly suggesting that he would spend so many resources to bait a trap?” Captain Baker shook his head.

“If that’s not a fake ship but a real copy of Horde Prime’s flagship, then Ba’al will have more forces protecting it. Not just double the fleet he sent against us,” Catra retorted. “So, whether this is a trap or not, if we attack it expecting to deal with a handful of

Horde frigates and his upgraded Ha'taks, we will be jumped by a lot more ships."

"Indeed." Teal'c nodded. "Ba'al has a reputation as a cunning foe. He would not merely place his guard ships in the open but attempt to hide them so an attacker will underestimate him and be drawn into his trap."

"Well, then we will spring the trap - send in a smaller force, and once he sends in his real force, we jump them!" Jack said.

That sounded like a recipe for a hell of a mess. Four forces trying to entrap each other? And possibly more on the way? Coordinating such a battle would be a nightmare.

"Sounds good." Catra grinned. If Ba'al's forces had one weakness, it was that they were bad at improvising on the spot without orders. Even if Ba'al managed to avoid getting jammed, his ships would be slow to react to any surprise. The more chaotic the battle, the bigger the Alliance's advantage would be.

"But where did he get the plans for Velvet Glove? Not even First Fleet had them; Horde Prime took that data into the grave," Bow said.

"More like into a space plant," Jack commented.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded several times. "Horde Prime didn't share that data with anyone. So… how did Ba'al get it?"

"Did he get it? He could just be trying to copy the appearance of Velvet Glove," Adora said. "If this is a trap, then it wouldn't matter if he had the real plans or not."

"Redesigning such a huge ship from scratch based on its appearance would be a challenge," Sam pointed out. She would know, having had to redesign the pieces of junk the Americans were building several times over. "You cannot simply scale up a smaller design - not with such a huge size difference. Just building engines able to move the ship at combat speed would be a

massive undertaking. I sincerely doubt that Ba'al would have managed that in the time since Horde Prime was defeated."

"What if he started before Horde Prime was killed?" Daniel asked.

"How?" Glimmer shook her head. "Horde Prime didn't even tell his clones about his plans; how would Ba'al have managed to get such data?"

Catra nodded. That was a good point. And to nip the next question in the bud, she said: "And if Horde Prime were still alive somehow, or Ba'al had enough information to fake his survival, he'd have taken over the Lost Fleet much more easily - and likely a lot more Clones."

Daniel raised a finger and opened his mouth but closed it again without saying anything.

"Preliminary analysis of the data we have would indicate that Ba'al is focusing on the parts of the original design that served as yards and factories for the Horde," Sam said. "He might be planning to get those functional and working, and install engines at a later date. Or treat the ship as a semi-mobile space station and move it with tractor beams or smaller engines if it needs to be moved, though he would still need a hyperdrive capable of opening a hyperspace window of this size."

"Still makes no sense, though," Jack complained. "Why build a station as if it were a ship if you can't build such a ship in the first place?"

"It might be the psychological effect," Daniel cut in. "By rebuilding Horde Prime's flagship, or building a space station in its image, Ba'al could claim to be his successor. That would likely increase the loyalty of the Clones serving him."

"All that effort just to make a statement?" Captain Baker sounded doubtful.

"It would impress a significant number of our sadly still lost brothers," Padre said.

"And the Goa'uld love to make such gestures to impress their rivals - and their own people," Daniel added. "Horde Prime was not merely a System Lord - his Empire was a peer of the Goa'uld Empire, at least. By claiming Horde Prime's mantle, Ba'al is elevating himself above all his rivals."

That certainly was true. But Catra didn't think Ba'al would go to such lengths just to make an impression. Still… "Also, if he can make them think he actually has a second Velvet Glove - or Horde Prime's flagship, the other Goa'uld might not know yet that it was destroyed - a number of them might think twice about attacking him. Especially if his forces use Horde technology. He might scare some potential enemies into joining him."

Adora nodded. "So, this ship is a symbol that will help him recruit more people for his armies and it will be producing large numbers of Horde frigates and other materials soon, but it can't move or be moved yet. That means we need to destroy it before it can move and we lose track of it - and preferably before it starts production."

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"Yep," Jack O'Neill said, "we'll have to destroy the massive space thingie before the evil space dictator turns it on and controls the Galaxy. And we'll have to deal with his entire fleet as we do so. All we need now is a commando raid to take out the thing's shields so we can destroy it, and George Lucas can sue us."

No one laughed. Carter even frowned at him, and Daniel rolled his eyes.

"You already made the Star Wars joke, Jack," Catra said.

Well, yes, he had - but a little humour never hurt anyone. Well, almost never. Some guys tended to react very badly to some jokes. Especially if they were about them.

“I have doubts that a commando raid would be useful for what seems to be a fleet engagement against a nonfunctional stationary spaceship of unusual size,” Captain Baker said. “What are the odds that they have a shield generator ready to cover the thing?”

“Nothing we have seen so far shows a shield generator or preparations for one,” Carter said. “Although the size of the ship means they could easily add multiple frigate-sized shield generators to cover it.”

“Those generally cannot withstand the focused fire of a squadron of frigates, much less a fleet,” Captain Baker said.

“Well… they would be harder to crack since they don’t cover an entire ship, just a part of it, and so they could focus their entire strength on a single side.” Entrapta scrunched her nose. “It would take four to six squadrons coordinating their fire to have the same effect on the shield, more or less - it depends on the exact shape of the shield and its size. If they spread it out so the surface area of the force shield remains the same as the surface area of a frigate’s shield, then the overall strength, and the firepower necessary to crack it, wouldn’t change compared to a frigate. Although the sheer size compared to a frigate means we’d need more firepower to actually disable and destroy it after the shields shattered.”

“That’s still a fleet target,” Captain Baker said.

“Yep,” Jack said. “But we also need as much intel as we can get - and that means boots on the ground. As soon as we know which ground to put them on, of course.”

“We already know the target’s location and that it currently cannot move - we have a spy bot observing the target providing us with almost real-time information,” the limey protested. For the captain of a fleet transport, he seemed very fixated on not getting to drop troops somewhere. “What more intel do we need? We already

know that their fleets are gathering at rally spots in deep space, not near a planet."

Jack shook his head. "We don't know enough about Ba'al's forces - not nearly enough. We've been stumbling into this half-blind, mostly reacting to his moves and rushing as soon as we get something. Now, we can watch that thing be built and take our time - the ship won't be ready any time soon, so we don't need to rush in before we get a bigger picture of Ba'al's realm."

"The longer we wait, the more ships he can build," Glimmer said with a frown.

"We're building ships as fast as we can as well," Jack retorted.

Catra nodded. "But we need intel to know if we're outbuilding him or not."

"The amount of resources going into this construction has to affect his other projects," Carter said. "This would be a massive drain for the Alliance."

"And what if he has the resources to spare? He's been at this for a thousand or more years," Bow said, "or so we heard."

"But he hasn't had access to Horde technology for more than a few years, tops," Catra pointed out.

"So we think," Glimmer shot back.

"Any way you cut it, we need more intel," Jack said. "And that means we need spies and scouts everywhere - including on that thing if we can manage that."

"The same spaceship we're about to destroy as soon as we get the orders to do it?" Captain Baker asked.

"Yep." Jack bared his teeth in a cocky grin. "Because one thing is certain: A snake as paranoid as Ba'al isn't going to let anyone else

control that project. Sooner or later, he'll visit. And I don't know about you, but I think we should make sure to nab him this time."

"Unless he sends another clone of himself," Catra said.

That was a distinct possibility. But Jack somehow doubted that Ba'al trusted even his own clones. "In any case, we need more spy bots and more scouting missions in every system in the area here - and on that ship." That would also keep his troops busy and sharp.

"But we can't wait too long - sooner or later, the ship will be functional," Glimmer said. "At least partially."

Catra shrugged. "We'll prepare a plan to destroy it with a raiding force. Shouldn't be that hard if we can get an enhanced Naquadah bomb inside it."

"We need to ensure first that there are no slaves trapped on the spaceship," Adora said. "We're not going to blow up the ship with hundreds or thousands of innocents in it."

Jack suppressed a wince. That would be tricky. "We'll have to drop a team directly on the spaceship, then. That will be a challenge even with a stealth shuttle."

Adora nodded. "I know, but we have to do it."

Well, Jack had asked for that.

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Base Portsmouth, PT-9521, PT-9521-System, June 28th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...and based on the most recent data, we can extrapolate that parts of the ship's factory section will be activated in a few weeks provided that they do not step up their efforts. While not conclusive, the workers seem to focus on those modules instead of weapons and shields - or propulsion, though since they are

using modular construction, that is not definitive; they could be adding weapon and shield modules quickly, as long as they construct them in the factory ships - they have the frames for the modules installed, and we, unfortunately, cannot tell from the data we have what exactly each factory ship is producing."

Adora nodded at Sam's report. That was what she had expected - a spy bot latched onto a ship guarding the construction could only do so much. It couldn't see into enemy hulls and any attempt to remotely hack the systems was impossible over such a distance even if they managed to get a connection to the Ha'tak's systems.

"So, it's about what we guessed - Ba'al is focusing on production. He wants a factory star, not a death star," Bow said.

Glimmer rolled her eyes, probably at his reference to Star Wars, but she nodded in agreement. "That supports the assumption that he is trying to build up his production capacity for Horde technology and is using his less advanced ships to keep us too busy to interfere."

"We don't have any hard evidence for that, though," Catra objected. "He launched one attack at this system; if he is trying to keep us too busy reacting to attack him to spoil his buildup, he would need to launch more attacks, both at this base and at others."

"Those attacks might still be happening; he might have sent out other fleets to strike at us - or he hasn't found more of our systems to strike at yet," Adora said. At least, with the spy bot network covering all of the Alliance systems and their surrounding areas, they would have some warning. Still, they couldn't cover every part with enough ships to repel a Goa'uld fleet with Horde technology, so they had to strike at the enemy's capacity to make war.

"As we keep saying, we need more intel about his plans," Jack said. "Old Ba'al is pretty frustrating that way."

“That's why we're going to sneak into his superfactoryship,” Catra said.

Adora nodded again. They needed solid intel about Ba'als plans, the forces at his disposal, and the extent of his territory. They couldn't defeat him if he could hide and build up his forces after every lost battle. She looked at Sam again, pointing at the holographic projection of the ship under construction and the factory ships and guard ships surrounding it. “So, can we sneak in there with a stealth shuttle?”

Sam straightened just a little bit. “The fact that they haven't dealt with our spy bots yet would indicate that our stealth generators are still beyond the enemy's ability to detect. Although we cannot exclude the possibility that Ba'al's forces are aware of the spy bots and using them to feed us carefully curated information in an attempt to manipulate us.”

“And how likely is that?” Glimmer asked.

“That is hard to say,” Sam replied. “We lack the intel about Ba'al's plans to determine that.”

Catra made an annoyed noise. “If Ba'al noticed the spy bots, he would be aware that his project's security is compromised and that we know about the ship being built, so he wouldn't have anything to lose by letting the spy bot keep operating and using the entire site as bait for a trap.”

“Nothing except for all the resources that keep being poured into building the ship,” Bow pointed out. “If this is a trap, he's risking losing it all.”

“He might consider that a price worth paying if he can take out our fleet,” Daniel said.

“But he doesn't know how many ships we have,” Adora said. “He couldn't be sure if he did enough damage to us to make it worth losing those resources.”

“Same as we don't know if he can afford to use this as bait or not,” Jack said. “I say we risk it. The longer we wait, the less time we have to react if we discover something bad.”

“Yes,” Catra agreed. “We can't just keep attacking blindly.”

“Given Ba'al's standard doctrine of compartmentalising his forces and keeping his commanders ignorant of his overall plans, even successfully infiltrating this factory complex might not reveal much more useful intel to us,” Sam said.

“But it will give us more information about his ability to produce Horde ships and weapons,” Jack said. “And we're bound to get a lucky break,” he added with a grin.

Catra snorted. “That's not how it works.”

Jack shrugged. “What else can we do? It's better than doing nothing.”

“Only if we don't get caught,” Catra shot back.

“We'll prepare a raid by the fleet as well,” Jack said. “That way, we have the cavalry waiting in case we need a rescue.”

“Yes,” Adora said. They needed the intel. “But we need to check out the ship in construction, the factory ships and the command ship of the forces there. So, we either split up, launch multiple teams or prepare for a longer mission so we can infiltrate one target after the other.”

“Never split the party,” Jack said.

“Between Bow, Entrapta and Sam, we can cover all three parts at once,” Glimmer objected immediately.

Jack shook his head. “Only if everything goes according to plan. It never does.”

Splitting up or sending more teams meant Adora couldn't protect everyone in case something went wrong. A longer mission was more complicated and also increased the chances that something would eventually go wrong, but they would be together.

"We'll hit them one after another," Adora said. "We might get lucky and find what we need on the first attempt."

Catra raised her eyebrows - she probably wasn't fooled about Adora's real reason - but the others agreed, if a bit reluctantly, in Glimmer's case.

Adora nodded firmly. "So, let's start planning our infiltration."

*****

Near Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter resisted the urge to personally check, once again, if the (slightly) improved stealth generator was working as intended. The readouts on her computer showed it was. And the improvements were nothing groundbreaking - just incremental improvements, increasing its power efficiency, dampening the already shielded emissions further and streamlining the routines that adjusted the stealth fields. Things they had done and tested on the way to the target while on board the flagship of this task force.

But a small part of her kept insisting that they needed more tests to be certain it worked, that they couldn't trust their current data, that the generator would fail in the worst possible moment.

The spy bot was still hiding, she told herself. The enemy sensors hadn't detected it, nor its transmissions. Of course, the spy bot was shielded by the bulk of the ship it was attached to - any stray emissions would either be absorbed by the Ha'tak's hull or attributed to the ship itself. That wouldn't be the case for the stealth shuttle here. And the stealth shuttle was significantly bigger than the spy bot, meaning its stealth field was bigger and

had a significantly higher power demand, which in turn meant more emissions had to be shielded, which was why she had spent the days in transit working on improving the shuttle, together with Entrapta and Bow.

All their data, including the analysis of the most recent examples of enemy sensor technology captured at the last battle, showed that the stealth field should work even at close distances - up to touching an enemy hull. Unless, of course, someone or something flew directly into it. No stealth field could hide a kinetic impact. But the odds of that were… well, not as low as Sam would like. They would be higher if they were to dock with an airlock on an enemy ship instead of going EVA and opening a lock manually, but even so, the shuttle's size was a disadvantage.

"It'll work, Carter."

She turned to narrow her eyes at the General. "I wasn't worried," she lied.

He clearly didn't believe her but nodded anyway.

"If it doesn't work, we'll throw Adora at them and hightail it out of there while the task force moves in to wreck the ship." Of course, Catra had overheard them and had to comment.

"Hey!"

Catra rolled her eyes. "As if you weren't planning to nobly hold them back while we escape!"

"Well…" Adora pouted, and Catra smirked.

And Sam felt better.

"So… let's do this!" The General clapped his hands together. "Everyone's in place, and things won't get any better if we wait any longer.

Sam was, out of principle, tempted to argue that, technically, that was incorrect - she could think of several ways where the odds of the mission's success significantly went up if they waited, such as if Ba'al was on the way for an inspection, but she could also imagine several ways where things would get worse if they waited, so she didn't say anything and focused on her computer. The enemy sensors didn't have the range to detect them out here, but you never knew.

"Yes," Adora said. "Let's start the mission."

The General moved to the cockpit, and Sam heard him ask for permission to launch half a minute later.

Permission was granted, and the shuttle lifted off - Sam could only tell thanks to the camera and sensor feeds; the inertial dampener worked perfectly. They left the hangar and quickly accelerated.

Then, the stealth generator was activated, and the ship's sensors switched to passive. Sam felt as if she had gone blind and deaf for a moment as the data feeds on her computer cut out, but all systems were working as expected, and the feeds were replaced with real-time data from the spy bot network a moment later.

"No change at the target," she reported. Construction continued at the already observed pace - she could see the icons of various transports shuttling materials back and forth between the 'Ba'al's Glove' and the factory ships surrounding it. There was no change in the guard force, either.

Everything was going according to plan so far. But that didn't mean anything - they were still too far out for anyone to detect them even if they didn't use the stealth generator. And they would take a while to reach Point Velvet since they wouldn't be using the hyperdrive for the last leg.

"I miss the fireworks," the General commented suddenly.

"What? Do you want us to be detected, Jack?" Daniel sounded aghast.

“No, I mean the fireworks back home. It's the Fourth of July.”

Sam didn’t need to see the General to know he was grinning widely.

“Oh, ah…” And Daniel would be pouting, having realised that he had been had.

But the small joke had lifted some of the tension inside the shuttle - she could hear snorts and chuckling - and Sam felt better as well.

Smiling, she went back to checking the data on her screen. She still had a job to do.

*****

Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

There it was: Ba'al's Glove. Catra liked the code name - it fit. Like a glove, Jack would say. And it removed some of the dread she couldn't help feeling when she saw it loom ahead. It looked too much like the original, well, like the original's lower-mid section. Same colour, same structure. At least from this far out. Up close, there were differences, as they knew from the spy bot's sensor coverage.

But they were approaching it, not yet close enough to make out such details, even with Catra's eyes, yet close enough so the missing parts didn't affect the impression it made as much any more.

She remembered her time on the original. Enough, at least, to feel sick. The days she spent afraid, trying to impress Horde Prime enough to be deemed useful, watching him play his sadistic games, his cruelness hidden behind false politeness and civility, until she couldn't take it - and her own guilt - any more and broke out Glimmer. And tried to die fighting the Clones, only to get captured and…

She shuddered at the fortunately vague memories of having the chip implanted in her neck, and her mind, maybe her soul, being changed - turned into a loyal drone of Horde Prime. The one thing she remembered most clearly from that moment was when her hair had been cut. She had done it herself, on his command. Let it fall to the floor.

And she remembered Horde Prime's frown at seeing the strands flutter around, spread across the room when she moved to kneel. The bastard must have hated it, but it had been his orders, so he couldn't complain. As far as payback went, it was very little, petty, but it was something.

And then he had sent her to fight Adora… Catra rubbed her upper arms with her hands when she remembered that. To fight her love - not that she had really realised, no, not that she had accepted that back then - all on the order of a sadistic megalomaniac…

She felt arms close around her shoulders. Familiar arms. Adora.

Her love didn't say anything, just held her. And Catra took a deep breath, closing her eyes for a moment. She was free. This wasn't Horde Prime's flagship. It was just a cheap copy still under construction - barely a space station yet, and not yet operational. And she wasn't alone; Adora was here. Her love.

She leaned into Adora's side and whispered: “Thanks.”

She didn’t see but felt Adora nod in return, even through her spacesuit.

Good.

And Melog was there as well, warmth filling her. She reached out and patted their head.

She was amongst friends. They would not let her down. And she wouldn’t let them down.

“Alright.” Jack's voice broke the silence in the shuttle. “There's our destination - a nice little maintenance hatch. Get ready to disembark while we close in.”

They had reached the ship while Catra had been… distracted. And the stealth generator was fooling the enemy sensors as expected - there was no reaction from all the guard ships and Death Gliders surrounding the Glove. None that they could see, at least. Ba'al might still be preparing a trap for them; he was the kind of enemy who would love such a ploy.

And they would turn it against him if he did. With a quip from Jack about George Lucas suing Ba'al, probably.

She smirked as she walked to the back of the shuttle, to the airlock.

Behind her, she heard Jack rise from his seat. “You've got the shuttle, Sha’re.”

“I've got the shuttle.” Sha're sounded a bit resentful - she didn't like staying back while everyone else entered the ship, and she had made that clear beforehand. But they needed someone qualified to stay on the shuttle, in case something went wrong. Or if it needed to move in case someone else used that hatch to do some maintenance or construction on the hull.

Or if they had to drop Emily on the hull somewhere so she could shoot her way into the ship - the bot hadn't liked staying back either, but she was too big and too loud to sneak through an enemy ship. At least until Entrapta managed to fit a stealth generator into her frame.

Catra stood next to Adora and didn't listen to Daniel whisper to Sha’re, nor to the sounds of them kissing, before he joined them at the airlock.

“Alright. Everybody is ready!” Jack announced. He talked a bit more quietly than usual - they didn't have to whisper; the vacuum outside wouldn't transmit sound even without the stealth field, but

you just didn't talk loudly when you were about to sneak into an enemy base or ship.

“Let’s go!”

The airlock on this shuttle had been modified to fit Emily, which had cut the cargo capacity down some but meant all of them would fit into the airlock without the bot. And that could be decisive in an emergency.

Catra felt the change in pressure as the air was pumped out, and a moment later, the outer door opened, and she was facing the maintenance hatch surrounded by the docking clamps surrounding it - non-magnetic since that apparently could be detected according to Entrapta.

“The section behind the hatch and airlock is clear according to our sensors,” Sam announced.

So, no Jaffa waiting in ambush right behind this door. Good.

“Keep scanning for suspicious gatherings of guards,” Jack ordered. “Don't want to walk into an ambush once we start exploring.”

“Yes, sir.”

Bow was already working on the door controls, and a minute later, the hatch slid open, and they entered the enemy ship.

Catra bared her fangs when she set foot in it.

*****

Ba’al’s Glove, Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

As bizarre as it was, Jack O’Neill’s first thought when entering the ship was that Ba’al had kept the Horde colour scheme. “It looks like Ba’al can’t afford gold-plating his new toy,” he said as the group moved through the empty hallway.

“It would clash with the theme,” Glimmer commented.

Catra, already ahead of him, snickered, but Jack had to glance at Glimmer to check if she was serious or not - she sounded a bit off. Oh. She had been kept prisoner on the original Velvet Glove. Of course, she would be a bit stressed walking in the same corridors.

“Well, if he is planning to symbolically, and maybe literally, take up Horde Prime’s mantle, he probably can’t change the aesthetics of the flagship much, if at all,” Daniel said. “I don’t think we can deduce that Ba’al’s suffering for resources from this.”

Way to miss the point, Jack thought.

“Constructing such a huge ship would be a drain on anyone’s resources,” Carter cut in as they reached an intersection. “Just the construction crew we discovered so far will require huge efforts to train, house and supply.”

That was good to know. And bad as well. Good because it meant blowing this ship up would harm Ba’al significantly. Bad because blowing up this ship would kill a lot of people whose only fault was having been born into slavery under the snakes. And Ba’al had proven that he would rather see his people die than flee or surrender.

Jack frowned. Maybe they could steal the ship with all the working crews on it? “So, the computer core you want should be in the central section, right?” He checked the map on his helmet’s HUD display. Yep, down in the centre of the ship as it was built so far.

“Yes, sir.” Carter nodded without looking up from her handscanner.

“I don’t suppose it’s the local nighttime, and we can just walk inside?” Jack grinned. He could see workers appear as the scanner updated their position.

“No, sir. They seem to be working around the clock. In two shifts.”

“Ah.” No eight-hour work days for Ba’al’s slaves. Of course, even twelve-hour work days were more generous than Jack had expected, but maybe Ba’al had learnt that having tired workers build his ships was a recipe for faulty craftsmanship. Which would be bad, of course, for the Alliance, but good for his slaves, in the short term.

“There’s a patrol of Jaffa headed our way!” Carter suddenly announced.

A moment later, the HUD display updated. Yeah, standard four-Jaffa squad on patrol. “Let’s hide,” Jack said, looking for a dead end… there! He marked the spot on the HUD and started walking. “Come on!”

The others followed. Carter slowed down a bit when she tried to operate her computer and hustle at the same time, but Entrapta picked her up with two hair tendrils, and they quickly caught up.

“Melog’s hiding us,” Catra announced.

Jack nodded. As he had hoped. The cat might be smug, but they were invaluable for such missions.

“They’re coming!” Catra whispered.

Jack held his breath when he heard the Jaffa’s footsteps. Here they came! And the leader looked straight down the dead end - if Melog weren’t hiding them, his eyes would have met Jack’s. And Jack would have shot him.

But as things were, the Jaffa patrol kept walking past, vanishing around the corner.

Jack glanced at Catra, who cocked her head to the side - would that help since she was wearing a spacesuit including a helmet? - before nodding. “They’ve crossed into the next section.”

They returned to the door, Bow hacking it while Carter and Entrapta kept an eye on the scanners, updating their HUDs.

As useful as it was to have a fully modelled three-dimensional map at his disposal that showed the positions of everyone, including the enemy, in almost real-time, for a moment, Jack couldn’t help feeling as if this was a video game. Between their sensors and Melog’s illusions, they could just walk to the computer core room, get all the data they wanted, and be back with the fleet for dinner.

Almost takes the fun out of risking your life on sneaky commando missions, he thought as they let a bunch of workers with a sled full of components pass, once again hidden by Melog.

Still, they had to bypass a checkpoint by going through the ventilation ducts - Entrapta took the lead there - since not even Melog’s illusions could make them pass through hatches watched by attentive guards.

Ba’al wasn’t using second-rate troops here. Another hint that this was the real deal and not some bait - although a trap would be more effective if your best troops were already present when it was sprung…

Jack clenched his teeth and checked his carbine once more when they reached the computer room for this section, and probably for the entire ship. This was going a bit too smoothly for his taste.

*****

“The computer room is not clear. Four people are using the consoles.”

Adora nodded at Sam's report. She could see it on her HUD as well - and she really needed such a thing when she wasn't wearing a spacesuit. But would that work with She-Ra's armour? Something to ask Bow later.

Now, she had to focus on the task at hand: Getting access to the computers without being detected. “Can you reach a console from the air duct vents?” she asked Entrapta.

“Hm…” Her friend cocked her head and peered at her tool, then slid her visor down and tilted her head back and forth - she must be using the HUD inside to study the room. “Maybe? It's a bit of a stretch. I might have to get into the room if it is too far to the closest port.”

“Melog says they can cover her in that case,” Catra said.

They had done that before, but Adora didn’t like letting Entrapta alone in a room with four enemies. Even though they were humans not Jaffa, and so they were workers, probably slaves, and not warriors. Ba'al's slaves were usually as fanatical as his warriors, and those were really bad.

“But they can't cover us in an illusion at the same time,” Catra added.

That was… not good. There weren't many good spots to hide in the ship here - Horde Prime had had much cleaner designs than the Goa'uld generally used, and it showed - but they would have to manage. Adora didn't see any other way around the problem, and having everyone stuck in the air ducts would probably be worse if they were detected. “Do it. We'll hide nearby.”

“OK!” Entrapta perked up - though Adora could only tell from her posture and voice; she was still wearing her visor down - and headed to the closest air duct, Melog padding after her - followed by Catra.

Adora bit her lower lip. Of course, someone had to go with them, just in case, and Catra was the obvious choice. Still… She didn't like it. “Let's look for a spot to hide!”

“There's a storage room relatively close,” Sam told her.

Adora checked the marked area on her HUD. ‘Relatively close’ was stretching it a bit. They wouldn't be able to provide immediate support should anything go wrong in the computer room. But if Adora went all-out, she'd be able to reach them quickly anyway. Hopefully. And it was the closest hiding spot. “Good.”

She watched Entrapta, Melog and Catra scramble up and disappear into the ventilation ducts, then moved to the storage room. They had to take a longer route this time since they couldn't hide behind illusions from the patrol, but they still made good time, and the storage room had plenty of crates to hide behind. Even Kyle would have managed to avoid detection from a casual glance here. Jack went as far as to claim he would take a nap in a corner since it was supposedly such a good spot, but everyone could see he wasn't serious.

"Alright! Here we are! I just need… Just a bit more… Ngh… Aw!"

"Entrapta's going in."

"Yes. It's just a tiny little bit too far. Even if I go half-in, which I did! Thanks for holding my legs, by the way!"

Adora closed her eyes and tried not to imagine how Catra and Entrapta must have looked right now.

"OK, here we go!"

Adora checked the HUD - no patrols nearby, and no workers coming their way, or toward the computer room. It shouldn't take Entrapta too long to hack the computers, so…

"And that's a good port! Download everything!

Not everything, Adora wanted to say, just the important data - but she knew that they couldn't tell what was important and what wasn't right away. So she had to wait and worry while Entrapta copied the database of what was a fleet base under construction.

"Almost done!"

Good. That meant...

"Fuck!" Catra's curse interrupted her thoughts.

"What?"

"What?"

"Entrapta, check the neck of the worker - check the necks of all the workers in here." Catra sounded very tense. But why?

"OK! We have to wait any… Oh!"

"What is wrong?" Adora hissed.

Catra replied in a flat voice: "The workers have Horde mind control chips."

Adora gasped and felt as if her stomach was dropping to the floor.

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Ba’al’s Machinations Part 7

Ba’al’s Glove, Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Ba’al is using mind control chips like Horde Prime did?” Samantha Carter hadn’t expected this. “This changes everything,” she said.

“Yes!” Glimmer hissed. “We can’t let him do this to anyone! We have to stop him!”

“We will!” Adora agreed.

“I agree, but that’s not what I meant,” Sam told them. “This was a part of Horde Prime’s technology that he kept from everyone. The Clones didn’t have access to that technology - they could use them, but they were built by automated fabbers, which the Clones could operate but not build themselves. Ba’al can’t have gotten this technology from the Clones he recruited.”

“Yeah.” The General nodded. “That means that this ship probably is the real deal, too.”

Right. If Ba’al had access to Horde Prime’s mind control chips, he probably had access to the Velvet Glove’s blueprints. And if he had that… “He must have had significantly more time to build up his production lines for Horde technology than we thought. We have to revise our estimates - and probably adjust our worst-case projections.” Worst case until now had meant that Ba’al would have gained access to Horde technology shortly after Horde Prime’s defeat three years ago. Now, it should be an even earlier access. “Although there is some good news as well,” she said.

“Yes?” The General looked at her. “Don’t tease us like that, Carter. Out with it - we really could use a bit of good news right now.”

Sam nodded. “If Ba’al has had access to this technology for years and still hasn’t been able to finish this ship - or finish upgrading

his older ships - then he can't have too many factories and resources, sir."

"Right." Glimmer grinned.

"Or he's been so stuck in keeping all his underlings isolated, he's been building up some of his fleets and neglected the rest entirely," the General pointed out.

Sam pressed her lips together. That was an alternative explanation that also made sense.

"And you say you're not a pessimist, Jack!" Daniel shook his head.

"Let's focus on getting off this ship - or station - now," the General said. "We can think about how to spoil Ba'al's plans once we're done here. And once we know them, of course. Which we hopefully will once all that data we just got is analysed." He grinned at Daniel. "See? I'm an optimist!"

Sam smiled almost against her will as she focused on her scanner. Catra, Entrapta and Melog were on their way back to them, but currently hiding in another room from a patrol. Which, Sam noted, would be crossing the corridor in front of their hideout as well.

"Now, let's be very quiet!" the General whispered before she could point it out. "We don't want to tip off Ba'al's Jaffa that we're here."

The automated data transfer from her sensor to the team's HUDs was working as intended, then. This should improve the performance of the Alliance forces in the field. If they could tap into an entire network, together with sensor fusion… Another reason to push the new armoured suits into production as soon as possible.

But she could write a memo about that later. The patrol was passing… no, they had stopped. Sam held her breath as the door was opened and then watched the Jaffa on her sensor enter and look around. If they discovered them… She glanced at the others. The General had drawn a zat'nik'tel, as had Teal'c - of course,

those were almost silent. Still, even if they could take out the entire patrol without alerting anyone else, a squad going missing would be noticed sooner or later, and Ba'al would know that someone had infiltrated his ship-building project.

She heard them coming closer - Ba'al evidently didn't alter the usual Jaffa armour, so their steps were quite noticeable - and drew her own zat'nik'tel. There were only four, so…

But shortly before they reached the crates behind which the team was hiding, they stopped, then turned and quickly left. Why would…? The others!

Sam checked her sensors. The three were clear but moving quickly.

"Catra! What happened?" Adora asked through their communicator.

"That's my line! We saw that you were about to be discovered, and Melog created a quick distraction."

Ah. Sam checked the sensor data again. "An accident at the production module?"

"Yes."

That would have been easy to arrange with Melog's illusions. Sam hoped that none of the workers had been hurt as a result.

But she knew that even if the affected workers avoided injuries, they would likely be punished by their superiors. That was how the Goa'uld worked.

But they had no choice in the matter - sometimes, innocents got hurt in war. They could only do their best to minimise collateral damage like that and to shorten the war.

And for that, they needed to get off this spaceship and check the other targets - but only after they ensured that those chips were

not being produced in this ship.

And for that, she needed more data about the chips so she could set the scanner for a deep sweep.

She focused on one of the workers in the computer room and set the details to the highest level. That should get more data about those chips.

*****

Catra suppressed another shudder when she approached Adora and the others. She was better than this. She had survived this. She could handle it. She didn't have a chip in her neck. She was free. Not under anyone's control. Not forced to fight her love at a madman's command. She was…

…rubbing the back of her neck to check. And Adora had noticed!

Catra whipped her hand down. She didn't need pity. She had gone through *that* already. "So, did you get more data on the chips? We need to hack them and free everyone!" she hissed when she reached the group.

"We've just finished a detailed scan and are still analysing the results," Sam replied.

Catra clenched her teeth. That was too slow! This shouldn't take any time! But she nodded. Rushing wouldn't help. Probably.

Adora moved over to her. She didn't say anything, just took her hand. Catra took a deep, shuddering breath and squeezed her fingers. "We can't let Ba'al use those chips."

"We've got protocols to keep him from turning our people," Jack said. "We already check for Goa'uld possession; chips are just one more check. He won't be able to infiltrate our troops like he did on Etheria."

“That’s not the point!” Catra retorted. “With those chips, he can control anyone as if he were possessing them.”

“There will be no surrenders - no honest surrenders - with those chips controlling Ba’al’s slaves and warriors,” Teal’c said. “He can force anyone to fight us until death.”

That was a more pragmatic argument, and a quite obvious one, but Catra could tell the others just didn’t understand the sheer evilness of it.

She saw Sam stiffen. She would get it - she had been possessed once before. Sha’re would understand as well.

“We can’t let people suffer like this,” Adora said. “This is the worst form of slavery. It’s evil! We need to stop this!”

“We’re working on it,” Sam said in a clipped tone.

“Let’s talk on the shuttle,” Jack said. “Not in the middle of the enemy ship.”

“Right.”

They made their way to the airlock, where Sha’re was waiting with the shuttle. Catra couldn’t help feeling guilty when she entered the shuttle. Leaving felt like fleeing. Like leaving the others to their fate.

“So, what do we know?” she asked as soon as everyone was gathered in the main area of the shuttle.

“They use FTL-communications,” Entrapta said. “Same as Horde Prime’s.”

“They are built exactly like the ones we have on file. Direct copies,” Sam added.

Catra clenched her teeth again.

“Tha’s a good thing, though - we know how to deal with them!” Entrapta announced with a wide smile. “We can hack the network with some effort. Although Ba’al will likely make changes after the first time.”

“Then we better get the whole network at once,” Adora said.

“That only works if he keeps it permanently connected. I somehow doubt he’s doing that,” Catra pointed out. Not when he was too paranoid to let his commanders know what the others of their rank were doing and how many others served Ba’al. So, waiting, and letting others suffer for longer, would be pointless.

“Yeah, can’t see him letting all his chipped slaves connect to each other,” Jack agreed.

“Yes.” Sam nodded. “We haven’t found any nodes outside this area - the network is limited to this task force.”

“And it is either something that Baal reserves for the most important locations or it’s very new. Otherwise, we’d have encountered the chips before,” Catra said. The shipyards they had taken had been very important, after all. “So, let’s crash the network here - no, take it over and use it to communicate with the slaves so we can get them out when we attack!” They would probably sabotage Ba’al’s fleet as well once they were free.

“That’s dangerous. Not the hacking, but letting them know about us? Some might be true believers and inform their god,” Jack said.

Catra shook her head. “Even if they were true believers, after being reduced to… after being chipped, they won’t be any more.”

Sha’re nodded. “Unless Ba’al would not have activated the chips yet, or has used a very light touch - which would be out of character for him - those people will have gone through hell, trapped in their bodies.”

Catra nodded. Sha’re got it.

“Ba’al’s been using a light touch with the Clones. We can’t assume he’s abusing everyone,” Jack disagreed. “And it won’t change much anyway if we just crash the network and then broadcast how to surrender, those who are freed will be able to act as they want.”

Catra didn’t like it, but he had a point. Underestimating Ba’al would be a mistake - this snake was very smart. “Any sign where those chips are made?”

“They aren’t manufactured here,” Sam said. “We could track the shipments using the sealed data we acquired.”

“Ba’al probably has a research base somewhere where he had his best workers develop and probably build the chips and other tools,” Catra said. “We need to find it and destroy it.”

She looked at Sam and Entrapta, but both were focused on working. They didn’t have a trace so far, then.

Damn.

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Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“So, we have two more targets to infiltrate,” Jack O'Neill said. He had to get the team back on track - they were here to gather intel and hit targets of opportunity, and, so far, they hadn't found any of the latter. As bad as the mind-control chips were, they couldn't just drop the mission. “Next stop: Factory ship.”

He could see that Catra was about to argue - the catwoman had taken their find quite badly, which was understandable but not helpful right now - but Adora nodded. “Yes. Let's go. We have to keep searching for more intel.”

Jack nodded and went to the cockpit. Sha're was a decent pilot, but he would take the con to approach the enemy ship. “Do we

have any intel on which we should pick?" he asked as he checked the passive sensors.

"There's no formal command ship for the factory units," Carter replied. "At least not based on their communication pattern. But I've marked the one producing the most advanced components. They will also require the most diverse resources, so we should have a decent chance to uncover more hints of the enemy supply routes. I've marked it."

"Sounds good," Jack agreed. Carter knew what she was doing.

He plotted a course toward the marked ship and started his approach. It wouldn't take long - all factory ships were very close to the Glove. He would have spread them out further in Ba'al's place. Harder to defend, but it would not concentrate all targets in a single spot. On the other hand, maybe the factory ships could serve as a sort of armour for the Glove, shielding it with their hulls - Ba'al's forces had used that tactic in their last-ditch attack on Base Portsmouth.

Still a bad idea; factory ships were primary targets. But Jack wouldn't complain. At this distance, they could probably crash a factory ship into the Glove before anyone could react and intercept it.

Not that they would do that, he reminded himself, since that would kill a whole boatload of people who were forced to work on either ship - some of them by mind control chips. Adora would never condone that.

And there was the target. Jack avoided the main hangars and docking ports - there was too much traffic there - and headed for another maintenance hatch, bringing the shuttle to a gentle stop just a yard off the factory ship's hull. "Alright, Sha're, you've got the shuttle."

"I've got the shuttle."

A last glance at the radar display - fed by passive sensors - to check there was no Death Glider patrol headed their way and then Jack was headed to the back of the craft, where the others were already lining up.

Carter and Entrapta were focused on their scanners, and Bow hacked the airlock easily enough, letting them enter.

The inside looked… Jack wouldn't say dirty or dingy, but compared to the Glove, the ship looked and felt older. Slightly worn. Like one of the older Navy ships back on Earth - he had been dropped off by the Navy on some missions, before Stargate Command. “Well, at least this ship's not new,” he commented as he looked around. “Too worn for that.”

“We'll have to verify that, sir.” Of course, Carter would say that. She always did. And she was correct.

But Jack would trust his gut feelings here. This ship wasn't new but had seen a lot of use, and even good maintenance couldn’t hide that. “So… is the backup we need to hit where it's supposed to be?” The main computer was on the ship's bridge, and Jack didn't think reaching it and stealing the data without anyone noticing would be easy, but the backup system was another thing.

“Yes, sir. This is a standard Horde design, same as we use.”

“Old Ba'al might have upgraded his ships,” Jack pointed out. He didn't really think so - why change what was working? The factory ship already used advanced technology - but you couldn't be sure until you had checked. Which they did.

The ship was actually busier than the Glove - at least the main corridors that the bots ferrying around material and components used; they looked like an anthill or termite nest on the model on Jack's HUD. But there were plenty of smaller, out-of-the-way corridors that were only used for maintenance, so it wasn’t too difficult to reach the backup storage room. They had only to

dodge one single patrol of Jaffa, which Melog easily handled, and then they reached their goal.

“Looks like they didn't need the backup yet,” Jack said as he looked around. “No empty pizza boxes around.”

Carter snorted and rolled her eyes at his joke, then explained it to Entrapta while they linked their computers to the main databanks here.

Jack checked the HUD while they worked. Nothing weird was going on. Just workers busy turning out components for Ba'al's Death Star, and minimal guards to keep them working.

That could mean Ba'al's forces were stretched thin - or that he trusted his mind-control chips to keep the crews in check. Though they hadn't been rolled out to everyone, yet - their scanner was marking the chipped workers, and those were only a handful in this ship, unlike on the Glove.

So, old Ba'al had only a limited number of the chips available - or a limited number of bots and surgeons to implant them. Either limit wouldn't last forever, though.

But Jack was sure they'd do something about the whole thing before that.

“Download complete, sir.”

“Then let's head back,” Adora said. “And then to the enemy flagship.”

Jack nodded. The sooner they were done, the sooner they could start preparing to wreck this entire operation.

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“There's the flagship of the task force guarding the site.”

Adora nodded at Sam and studied the display. It was a regular Horde frigate. As with all the other frigates they had encountered in Ba'al's service, there were no signs of any modifications - externally. Internally, they couldn't be certain, but the analysis of the wrecks and intel from prisoners and deserters had not shown any hints of modifications, either. It seemed Ba'al was more focused on upgrading his old designs to Horde specs than experimenting with his new ships. Unless that was done somewhere else with a wholly different force. Trying to guess what Ba'al was doing had quickly become a very frustrating activity.

Still, they knew very well how a Horde frigate was laid out internally, so they should know what to expect when docking at this ship. “Alright,” she said, “take us in.”

The frigate shouldn't have better sensors than the factory ships, either, so this should be pretty safe. A bit more challenging to find a hatch to hack and use, a frigate was significantly smaller than a factory ship, but not impossible either.

Jack was already closing with the flagship, using a sweeping approach that would see them docking to the underside of it, where an escape hatch was installed. Horde Prime hadn't been big on his clones abandoning ships while they could still fight but he had liked the idea of wasting them even less. Probably because he considered them parts of him or something similarly narcissistic, Adora thought.

Whatever the reason, they had a way in that led to a supposedly - and now that they were in range of their scanners, confirmed - deserted storage room. Once again, the stealth generator worked - they were parked right between the aft part of the underside beam cannon batteries - and Bow could easily hack the airlock's door and security system.

Adjusting to the fact that the direction of the artificial gravity generator of the ship and the shuttle were not aligned so that they had to sort of walk-climb into the frigate was actually the

biggest challenge here - Adora carried Daniel inside to speed things up.

But the storage room was full of rather un-Horde things.

“Looks like we got lost in some snake's attic,” Jack commented.

And indeed, the room had a few very ornate crates inside, and jars and bags, all in the Goa'uld style. They looked very weird inside a Horde-style room.

Daniel checked the hieroglyphs on the crates. “Not a Goa’uld, Jack. These seem to be the personal belongings of Mal'ak - First Prime of Ba'al.” He pointed at a plaque on the largest chest.

“Really?” Jack peered at them. “And he stores them here, way out of the way?”

“A Jaffa serving their false god is not supposed to revel in luxury,” Teal'c said. “He might pretend to live frugally, or as Earth would say, in spartan quarters, as a show of loyalty.”

“While hiding his loot and ill-gotten gains here? That doesn't sound very honourable.” Jack grinned.

“There is no honour in serving the false gods,” Teal’c replied. “And once a Jaffa realises that, they have to consider how to react. Some decide to retain their honour despite the price they have to pay. Others decide to let go of their honour altogether and imitate their oppressors’ desire for power and wealth.”

“It's too bad that we're on a covert mission - I'd love to rob this guy,” Jack said.

“Well, let's see what we're missing at least,” Catra said, flashing her fangs in a wide grin as she approached the largest chest.

“Catra!” Adora snapped.

“It's intel!” her lover replied - though she kept grinning. “We might find out which planet he fought and served on by analysing his loot.”

“Sounds legit to me.” Of course, Jack agreed.

Adora shook her head. “Check for traps.”

“Of course.” Catra looked at Bow.

Bow sighed. “Let's see…”

“The scanners don't detect any traps,” Entrapta said. “At least no traps we could detect.”

Adora could have done without hearing that qualifier.

“Good enough for me!” Catra fiddled with the lock and then popped it open and raised the lid. “Oh!”

“A lot of different pots and jugs,” Entrapta said.

“Which you saw on the scanner already,” Catra told her.

“I didn't want to ruin the surprise!”

Sam was focused on the rest of the ship, Adora saw. To warn them of any guards approaching.

“Those are very diverse designs and styles!” Daniel sounded very excited and almost pushed Jack and Catra away from the chest. No, not almost - he did elbow Jack out of the way without noticing when he reached into the chest and pulled out a pot. “Minoean! But I don’t recognise the patterns! And Phoenician, though that was to be expected given Ba'al's history on Earth. But confirmation is always good.”

“Forget the pots. Look at that!” Catra reached inside and pulled out another object.

Adora blinked. It looked like it was broken. And it wasn’t a pot or jug, but a cube - maybe a cubic pot? Those existed. And she had seen this before…

“It's the same design as the alien data cube!” Entrapta sounded even more excited than Daniel now.

Adora wasn’t sure if that was a good thing.

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Flagship of the Guard Force, Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

That was an alien data cube - the remains of an alien data cube, Samantha Carter corrected herself. Why was this amongst what looked like the loot from one of Ba'al's more trusted commanders? It was just part of the cube's shell, so maybe it was a curiosity in a collection, looted from one of Ba'al's enemies - or victims. But if Ba'al had found a base or a planet settled by this civilisation, maybe gained access to their technology… “We need to find out where the owner of this chest acquired this,” she said.

“Yes!” Entrapta agreed enthusiastically. “If we find out where they got it, we could find more clues to decrypt our own cube!”

Which, Sam reminded herself, they should have done long ago. Obviously, they should have treated the artefact not as some curiosity but as a priority. More important than, say, dealing with the design faults of the latest abomination from procurement.

“Well, for that, we'll need to find the owner of the chest.” the General said.

“That would probably be the commander of this site,” Daniel said. “As we mentioned before.”

“‘Probably’.” The General shook his head. “But we've been a bit unlucky lately by making guesses. Wouldn't want to nab the wrong guy.”

“Then let's take the entire ship!” Catra bared her fangs in a grin. “That way, we got everyone on board - as long as we can keep them from suiciding.”

“Taking the ship kind of ruins the secrecy part of our plans,” the General pointed out - but Sam could see that he liked the idea. It was his kind of plan, daring and decisive if it worked. And a spur-of-the-moment decision.

“And if we take out their command ship, the rest of the guard fleet will be easier to deal with by our task force,” Glimmer said.

“But we can't attack before we have a plan to save the workers,” Adora said. “If Ba'al is willing to sacrifice them rather than let us rescue them…”

Sam pressed her lips together. With the mind-control chips, no one would refuse Ba'al's orders, and he only needed a few key people chipped to ensure the factory ship and the Glove would be destroyed. With the size of this operation, the death toll would be horrible.

“If we take over the ship before the rest of the guard fleet realise it, we can fake orders to split up - or claim we were called away,” Catra said. “Have the guards rally in an ambush location, or just send them on a trip to attack a system at the other end of the galaxy.”

The last suggestion was probably not meant seriously, but if they could take over the flagship of this force, then taking the entire site over with minimal casualties would be a realistic objective for this mission. Ba'al was fond of compartmentalising his forces, but the individual forces’ command structures were very hierarchical, as expected from a tyrant.

“Can we take over the ship without alerting the rest of the guard ships?” Daniel asked. “We could head back to our task force and gather more people.”

Sam pondered the challenge. If they managed to manipulate the life support system… They had no gas with them to render the crew unconscious, but if they changed the settings, they could alter the ship's atmosphere gradually and reduce the oxygen until the crew was out. But the risk of killing anyone with this was great. Maybe…

"We need the bridge, engineering and the hangar," Catra said. "To control the ship and ensure that they can't alert anyone else or sabotage it." She looked around. "If we leverage the element of surprise and She-Ra, that's doable, but we need to be quick to get everything and everyone moving afterwards before things start going wrong. "If we take over the bridge and then have the rest of the crew gather in the hangar for an inspection, we could take them out all at once."

That was… Sam looked at the General.

He was grinning broadly. "Good idea! But we need to make sure they aren't locked up with anything they can use to get free - or shoot a hole in the hull to alert the rest of Ba'al's guards.

"We can lock them in with She-Ra," Catra said. "That will keep them from ruining the plan."

Adora nodded. "Yes. I can deal with the frigate's crew. But we need to secure the bridge and then imitate the commander."

"We can do that by taking records of their voice and then using our computer to turn the samples into orders," Entrapta suggested. "Though that might take a while."

"Let's hope he isn't the silent type," the General joked.

"We should be able to get voice samples from the ship's databanks," Sam said. "Communication is generally recorded."

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "And we need access to the central computer anyway, for the rest of the data!"

“And the bridge offers access to the computers,” the General added. “So, let's go and take it over.”

“After we check that the commander is on the bridge,” Bow said. “We can’t imitate his orders if he can countermand them.”

“Right.” Adora looked at Sam and Entrapta. “And we need to find out who the commander is. Scan the entire ship and look for anyone who could be it. And scan for mind-control chips. If you don't find anyone who could be it, we need to get access to the backup databanks so we can identify the commander.”

“Yes!” Entrapta nodded with a smile, and she and Sam started working.

*****

“We’ve detected six mind-control chips currently active on this ship. One of them is a Jaffa, the others are Clones.”

Catra felt relieved at Sam’s report. If the flagship of Ba’al’s guard force didn’t have more mind-controlled crew members, then that probably meant that he didn’t have too many chips available. That was… reassuring.

“So… Those could be three shifts of two people, like the captain and the first officer, the chief engineer and his number two, and the Commander of the entire force and his second-in-command,” Jack said. “The commander would be Mal’ak.”

“Mal’ak might here as an envoy or to inspect the site, not as its commander,” Glimmer said.

“Not nominally, but as Ba’al’s First Prime, he’d be in charge anyway,” Sha’re said.

“We don’t know if Ba’al would use those chips on his commanders,” Daniel said. “That could drive them to rebel or even desert, as long as they realise what is happening in time to react.

He might use them on guards to keep an eye on his commanders."

"His commanders are likely the most faithful of his followers," Glimmer objected. "They would probably agree to the chips to show their loyalty."

"But would he trust them even if that were the case?" Adora asked. "The Jaffa is probably Mal'ak - we know that two of Apophis's First Prime defected, and Ba'al likely knows that as well."

"With how shoddy Apophis's counter-intel work is, half the Galaxy knows this," Catra said with a snort. "But for a mind-controlled guy, that's a lot of loot." She gestured at the chests. "Why would Ba'al let him keep it after mind-controlling him?" She wouldn't call it 'chipping'. That would make light of its horror. She also wanted to tell the others that, but she didn't want their pity. And this wasn't the time for that, anyway. They had to focus on the mission.

She saw Melog glow a little and hoped that the others missed it - she didn't want anyone to know how she felt.

Okay.

She felt Melog's confidence and trust and relaxed a little.

"Ba'al might use the chips as a fail-safe in case his followers betray him," Teal'c said. "His First Prime might not even be aware of what the chips actually do - the false gods always lie to their followers. Further, Ba'al has a reputation for being untrustworthy even for a Goa'uld."

"Yeah," Jack said. "Not telling even his Prime what the chips are and do seems a thing Ba'al would do. The guy seems too paranoid to tell even his highest-ranking followers more than the absolute minimum. Anyway, those are our main targets. Take them out, and their command structure should be in shambles."

“Let’s hope so,” Adora said, then looked at Catra.

Catra nodded. “Our priorities are the bridge and engineering, but we cannot let anyone with a mind-control chip walk around - they would sacrifice themselves without hesitation to get us or just to deny the ship to Ba’al’s enemies - and we absolutely need to control all communications.”

“We can hit the scuttling charges first and disable them so they can’t just blow the ship - and us - up,” Entrapta said. “And we can hack the communication systems.”

“That would still leave individual FTL-communicators,” Catra said. “We need to jam those as well.”

“That would affect our communication with the other ships,” Sam pointed out. “They might realise something is wrong.”

“Better they suspect than have someone alert them - we can’t fight the guard force in this ship,” Catra said. “So… Where are the mind-controlled people?”

“We’re tracking them. Two, including the Jaffa, are on the bridge, one in engineering, one in the main hangar and two in the crew quarters,” Sam replied.

“Are they in the officer’s quarters?” Daniel asked. “I mean, I know the Horde frigates didn’t have special quarters for their officers since all Clones were replaceable for Horde Prime, but if Ba’al is integrating the Clones into his forces, this might have changed.”

That was a good point, but probably not relevant.

“The quarters look the same as on a regular frigate, except for the commander’s. That was remodelled. Potentially to better serve as a flagship and accommodate a Jaffa commander,” Sam said.

Catra nodded and studied the holoprojection for a moment, checking the targets. “So… Adora and Entrapta to the bridge. Bow and Glimmer to Engineering. “Melog and I take out the one in the

hangar. Jack, Sam and Teal’c take out the two in their quarters. And Daniel and Sha’re stay in the shuttle and act as our network hub.” She looked at the others.

Yes, Melog thought.

“Yes,” Adora said. “Keep the maps updated. We have to travel carefully without Melog covering all of us.”

Sorry.

“Don’t be,” Catra told him. “We need you in the hangar since that’s a wide space, and we can’t take out everyone there before they raise the alert, so we need to be sneaky there.”

Yes.

Good. Catra checked her HUD and saw the tracked figures multiply, covering all crew. A moment late, routes appeared on the display, most of them going through air ducts and vents. Entrapta was adapting the data, then.

Catra grinned. “Let’s go!”

“Yes.” Adora nodded with a firm expression. “Let’s go.”

They split up. Without Melog's power, the other groups would have to carefully pick their way to their targets, as often through the vents as not. Catra didn't have to bother with that. Melog could hide them from plain sight - in the middle of a corridor, if needed. They didn't go quite that far - that would have been an unnecessary risk; one slip and a Clone might stumble into them in the narrower corridors - but the temptation was there. Especially when they were waiting in an alcove for a group to walk past. At least Goa’uld ships were crewed by Jaffa, and they usually marched at a brisk pace; the Clones walked more leisurely. Horde Prime probably thought having his ‘brothers’ walking faster would have made it seem as if they were rushed and that might make him look as if he weren't on top of things at every moment.

Still, even with those delays and despite the larger distance, they reached the main hangar before everyone else reached their targets. And their target was obvious - even if the HUD feed from Sam and Entrapta's scanners wouldn't have marked him for Catra, he would have stood out; the Clone stood on a small pedestal in the back of the hangar, watching everything, and Clones regularly came to him for something or the other while maintaining the Horde fighters and their bot pilots lined up in the hangar.

That was a new setup compared to the Horde standard layouts, she noted. The pedestal, not the fighters; those were standard issue. But in the Horde, all the Clones had been supposedly equal before Horde Prime (and beneath him), and such overt signs of their higher positions had been absent. That had changed in the Alliance, but mostly for functionality - they had a dedicated control room for the hangar master, not some platform to look down on the rest.

But it made taking the man out without alerting everyone a bit tricky. Not too much, though. She looked the situation over, studying the patterns of the Clones at work - fewer than in an Alliance frigate for the same tasks; had Ba'al some manpower problem? - and the doors leading out from the hangar.

A quick check with the ship's layout on her HUD later, she had her plan.“Can you copy him walking out of the hangar?”

Positive.

Good. “Then cover us as we head over behind the guy.”

Yes.

They moved carefully along the walls, quickly passing in front of the two doors on the way so they wouldn't run into some Clones coming and going, until they were standing behind the hangar master's pedestal.

“Hangar group ready,” she reported over the communicator.

"Copy. Bridge group still en route."

"Crew Quarters en route."

"Engineering en route."

More waiting, then. She suppressed a sigh - Melog couldn't hide sound - and watched their target.

He was rather brusque with his underlings, Catra noted in the next few minutes. Quite different from what she was used to from the other Clones she knew. Even Horde Prime had played the affable, gentle leader towards his 'brothers'. She pressed her lips together when she looked at the Clone's neck where the mind control chip would be located, hidden by his clothes. How much of his attitude was his own and how much resulted from being mind-controlled by a Goa'uld? Well, if things went according to plan, they would find out.

"Bridge group in position."

Adora and Entrapta were ready. Good.

"Engineering group in position."

So were Glimmer and Bow.

About a minute later, Jack reported as well.

"Crew Quarters group ready."

"Go!"

At Adora's command, Catra nodded at Melog. A moment later, she caught the faintest flicker as their illusion settled over the hangar master.

Go.

She dashed forward, drawing her zat, and shot the Clone from the back, catching him as he collapsed and dragged him back to the

wall.

There, she quickly checked his clothes for weapons, relieved him of a zat, slung him over her shoulders and then made her way out of the hangar while Melog made it look as if the Clone had received a call on his communicator and then left by himself.

A minute later, they were outside, hidden in a side corridor.

“Hangar group, done.”

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Ba’al’s Machinations Part 8

Flagship of the Guard Force, Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Go!”

As soon as Adora’s order came over the communicator, Jack O’Neill rose, zat in hand, aimed at the door in front of him. A moment later, it slid open - Carter had hacked the controls. He rushed inside, already turning to aim at the figure he had marked on his HUD.

The Clone was sitting up on his bed. “Oh, what…”

Jack shot him. Once.

The Clone collapsed, stunned, and Jack rushed to secure him with zip ties - advanced restraining devices with much higher tensile strength than steel, according to Carter, but he knew zip ties when he saw them. He searched the Clone for any weapons and devices, tossing out a Horde-style gun, then flipped him over and secured his hands and feet. Better safe than sorry.

Then he lifted the guy on his shoulder and moved to the door.

“Hangar Group done.” Catra sounded smug. Well, anyone could kidnap a guy quickly if they had an illusion-casting cat with them.

The corridor was clear according to the HUD, but Jack O’Neill still peeked around the corner to check before moving out of the room. He trusted Carter with his life, but even she or her technology weren’t perfect. And this would be a hell of a time to discover that the magic sensor glitched and overlooked a patrolling squad of Jaffa or Clones because they were wearing funny hats or something.

Carter and Teal’c were ahead of him, in the second target’s quarters. He closed the door behind him - no clones moving

nearby, according to the HUD - and quickly made his way to them. "Carter? Teal'c?" he asked as he entered. "You've got two?"

"This is the target." Teal'c pointed at a Clone who had a chip port in the back of his neck. "We have not yet identified the other."

"Well, they look alike. Maybe his twin?"

Carter rolled her eyes. Teal'c didn't react at all, and Jack sighed. "So… any chance he's someone important?"

"I would need access to the ship's system to identify him. Or check a restricted door's controls for access privileges, sir," Carter replied.

"Let's leave him here, then, and lock the door behind us. We're on a tight schedule," Jack said.

"Indeed." Teal'c grabbed both their guy and Jack's.

"Let's go!" Jack turned to the door to check the corridor and used his communicator. "Crew Quarters group, done."

"Engine Room group, done."

Good. That only left the bridge. Where Adora and Entrapta were.

*****

"Crew Quarters group, done."

"Engine Group, done!"

Adora took a deep breath as the last Clone on the bridge slid down the wall into which she had kicked him. Maybe a bit too hard - he didn't move. But she had knocked him down earlier, yet he had recovered and had been about to shoot at Entrapta. So… his own fault.

She looked around. Half a dozen bridge crew, four guards, the captain and Mal'ak - probably; he had a mind-control chip and

was the only Jaffa on the bridge - were knocked out.

“Bridge group, done,” she said into her communicator.

“Not yet!” Entrapta called out. “I’m still trying to hack into the system here. Well, systems - we need the data banks, backups and the security system, but also communications. And weapons, or they could shoot at someone to alert them. Or trigger them to fire back. So…”

Well, they had control of the bridge, at least. The rest would come in time. Adora touched the button on the earring Entrapta had made for her, and a HUD appeared in front of her eyes. She could see the others. Glimmer and Bow were holding the engineering section, and Catra’s group was moving toward Jack’s group so they could merge and join Adora on the bridge. Good. By the time they reached the bridge, Entrapta would have…

Something moved to her right! Adora spun around. Mal’ak was getting up - and he was aiming a zat’nik’tel! At Entrapta! Adora threw herself between the two, but Mal’ak was faster - his shot hit Entrapta in the back, and she collapsed. His second shot hit Adora’s shield, though.

She bared her teeth as she rolled and rose, facing him. He shot a third time, and she caught it on her shield again as she rushed him.

She hit him, shield first, and he flew several yards back, crashing into and over a console, flipping head over heels, before slamming into the wall.

She drew a sharp breath when she saw the red smear he left on the wall. Had she killed him? She glanced at Entrapta; her friend was breathing. She had only been hit once, so she was simply stunned.

Adora rushed to the downed Jaffa. He, too, was still breathing but bleeding massively from his head. That was…

He suddenly rolled away from her, reaching for his dropped zat.

Adora stepped on the zat, crushing it, and shook her head. "Surrender!"

He looked at her with an empty expression, then grabbed her lower leg and…

…tried to pull her down. As if!

She kicked him again, not too hard, and he flew back into the wall - but got up again and came at her.

A bash with her shield set him flying once again. Adora heard bones break this time.

Yet, he got up - or tried to. Adora grimaced when she saw his leg give in and the broken bone push through his skin. That…

She blinked. He wasn't showing any reaction - his expression looked almost bored!

Oh, no - the chip must be controlling him!

"What the…?"

"They woke up!"

"Watch out!"

All the chips had been activated.

*****

"What the…?"

Samantha Carter whirled to the side as soon as she heard the General, drawing her zat'nik'tel. Both the Clone Catra was carrying, as well as the two Teal'c had slung over his shoulders, were jerking wildly, trying to get free - no, trying to *bite* them.

Catra slammed her clone into the ground, hard enough, Sam heard bones crack. Yet the Clone didn't stop - didn't even cry out. No reaction at all!

Teal'c had dropped his two, kicked one away and pinned the other with his staff. But they wriggled on the floor - and were pulling against the restraining devices with enough force to make their wrists bleed!

Sam shot one with her zat'nik'tel before he managed to wound himself even worse.

It didn't stop them.

Sam almost shot the prisoner again before she could stop herself. A second shot so close to the first would kill him.

And probably not stop him, either. "The chips are controlling them!"

The general cursed and used his communicator. "Change of plans - we've been made! Signal the task force to attack and get this ship out of here!"

"Entrapta's stunned. I've healed her, but…"

"Oh… what happened?"

"You were stunned."

"Oh."

"Jam the communications! Crash their comms if you can!" Catra snapped.

"Oh, right."

But Entrapta sounded still a bit out of it - Sam could tell. Even though Adora had healed her.

Another crack made her glance at Teal'c. Her friend had just broken more bones of their prisoners. Pragmatic yet brutal.

Sam winced and focused on her computer. She had to link up with Entrapta's tool and, through it, to the main computer. They had to take over the ship! But first, the task force.

It took several seconds for the computers to link up - Entrapta was not quite as quick, yet, as she usually was - but Sam managed to send the signal to the fleet.

"They've alerted the crew!" the General said. "We need to get to the bridge. And hold engineering."

Sam quickly shut down all doors she could access. That would hopefully trap some of the Clones. But not all - and they were cutting through the blast doors in the corridors.

"We've sealed the door, but they're shooting at it."

Glimmer sounded… controlled. Not openly worried. Not yet.

"Working on the hyperspace window!" Entrapta reported. Sam could see that on the screen of her computer.

"And someone needs to reinforce Engineering Group," Catra said. "I'll go - you go with the rest to the Bridge. Yes, go with them. I'll be fine."

She was arguing with Melog, Sam realised, then pushed the stray thought away as she started to adjust the comms.

The enemy fleet had been alerted - the chips must have been tapped into the comm network and registered when their carriers were stunned. Or attacked. Obvious, in hindsight. Sam did what she could to throw them into disarray, sending out conflicting orders and flooding the network with data and requests for more data. Fortunately, they were on the enemy flagship - and their signals and orders were prioritised by default.

But the enemy was adapting - a squadron had just gone off the network. They would move against the flagship.

"The door's glowing."

"I'm almost there!"

Shots rang out around the corner. Carbine, M4. The General. Then blasts - Teal'c.

"We need to move! They're coming!"

"I'm almost done!" Sam protested. "I need to crash their network. If that squadron managed a coordinated attack… She tagged them as hostile and sent orders to the rest of the fleet to destroy them.

A third of the ships started moving to intercept the squadron. A few more started towards the flagship.

Sam modified the orders again. This time, they looked as if they came from the ships that had dropped off the network. The confusion wouldn't last long, but…

"Alright, we're opening the hyperspace window as soon as we're moving!"

"I've cleared the door to the engine room but it's too hot to open. Bow, what's the engine doing?"

"Uh… It's starting up."

"It's supposed to do that! We're about to enter hyperspace!"

And they were about to get shot by half the enemy fleet. Sam's efforts had delayed a coordinated response, but there was only so much you could do if the enemy had a secure network through their chips…

But before the first ship could do more than diminish their shields, they entered hyperspace, and Sam relaxed. They were safe, for the moment. At least the ship was - the General and Teal’c were shooting again. And Sam could see Melog next to her, probably shielding her with illusions.

“I’m coming back to you. Glimmer and Bow are safely sealed up!”

“Hey!”

“She’s right, Glimmer - if we can’t get out, they can’t get in.”

But the chipped prisoners were still trying to attack Sam - she saw one of them trying to roll toward her with broken bones sticking out of their limbs. This was horrifying!

A quick check of her display showed that most of the still-moving crew members were trying to storm the bridge.

Sam pressed her lips together. Charging Adora in a corridor? She knew how that would end. And she could also see that Catra was almost back with Sam’s group.

Good. They just needed to hold until they reached the end of their trip and the Alliance marines could board the ship.

*****

Catra checked on her HUD one last time as she rushed down the corridor on all fours. All the enemies were facing Jack and Teal'c, holed up with Melog and Sam in a dead end a bit ahead.

Good.

She rounded the last corner and pounced on the Clone at the back of the enemy formation, landing on his shoulders and smashing his forehead into the floor while she jumped at the next one.

Her claws slashed through his weapon and fingers as she rammed him into the wall, leaving him stunned and bleeding as she pivoted and darted forward again.

The others were starting to react, turning around and crying out in alarm, but she was in the middle of them before they could form a line and dropped to the floor between the two closed, slicing their ankles before they could bring their weapons to bear, then finished them off with a quick series of kicks to the head.

That left three more, caught between her and the others. One tried to shoot her, but she darted to the side, making him miss, then rushed forward, dodging under his aim, to grab his arm. A quick twist broke his arm, making him drop the weapon, and she turned, throwing him into the next one before he could shoot, sending both to the floor, sprawling.

Jack moved up and shot the last one, then stunned the two others before they could recover. “We need to get to the bridge.”

She checked her HUD. There were still quite a number of the crew moving around, though they didn't seem too organised any more. And yet… if the crowd in the hangar hit engineering, Bow and Glimmer could be in trouble. “Go. I'll run interference to keep them from getting their act together.”

He nodded. “We have three prisoners we can't stun.”

“They have been rendered unable to attack us,” Teal'c said. Behind him, one of the bound and gagged Clones on the floor tried to hit his ankle with his forehead, and he moved to the side. “Mostly.”

They had all limbs broken but didn't stop trying to fight, Catra noticed with a wince. If Horde Prime had used his chips like that… “We need to hack the chips to free them.”

“We need to get out of hyperspace and have the ship secured first,” Jack said. “We're still trying to take over a ship with just us against the entire crew.”

Catra clenched her teeth. “As long as those chips are working, the enemy ships won’t stop fighting.”

He nodded and glanced over at Sam. “Carter?”

“Entrapta is handling the ship's controls and keeping us on course. Sir, I am blocking communications and weapon systems so they cannot fire on our allies or call for help. But if they track the mind-control chips, they will locate us anyway.”

“Right. Hack the chips first.”

“Yes, sir.”

Good. Catra nodded and left them. She had a ship to roam and crew to take out. At least the regular Clones were easy to disable and not some mind-controlled zombie warriors. But she really didn't want to face a horde of Jaffa controlled by such chips. You'd have to kill them all to stop them, and she wouldn't put it past those evil things to keep a dead body fighting for a while.

Up ahead, three Clones were trying to bypass the locks Sam had put on the beam cannon battery there. She tore through them in seconds, leaving them bleeding and knocked out. The hangar was ahead. It looked like the remaining clones there - half of the hangar crew had been attacking engineering, and Catra had dealt with them already - were trying to get a fighter ready.

That wouldn't do. Catra took a shortcut through the air ducts, scrambling through the narrow space with her claws digging into the material, then slashed the grill and dropped into the hangar, right on top of a Clone dismantling the door controls.

She left him with his head stuck in the controls and rushed the next group. They tried to form a firing line as if this were a field battle but were too slow - and too unused to ground battles; two shot each other when Catra dived between them to sweep their feet, and a third seemed caught between moving to a spot from where he wouldn't hit anyone else but Catra and holding his position.

She took him out with a blow to the head when he decided to charge her instead, then used him as a shield to catch the blast from the last one. A quick charge smashed the smoking corpse into the shooter, and both into the console behind them.

Catra jumped over them, landing behind the console, moments before a volley of blasts hit both Clones and the console.

The rest of the hangar crew had noticed and formed up, including a few bots. Those had no trouble with ground combat and were advancing on her, as her HUD showed.

She grinned as she looked at the enemy formation. It was almost perfectly aligned - Horde Prime would have been proud.

But it was also almost perfectly lined up in front of the closest Horde fighter.

She jumped out of cover - it was disintegrating under the blasts anyway - and ran on all fours across the hangar. The Clones were slow to adjust their fire, the bots barely better, and she reached the fighter ahead of their shots.

A slice with her claws cut the forward landing strut, and the fighter tipped forward, nose hitting the floor. While the Clones shot the cockpit to pieces, she dug her claws into the right side, cutting off a part as tall as herself and twice as wide.

Makeshift shield ready, she rushed the line, catching the blasts until she was in the middle of their formation.

Then she cut loose.

*****

Never split the party, Jack O'Neill reminded himself as he rounded the next corner, leading with his carbine. “Clear!” he called out. The HUD had shown him no one was there before he had reached the corner, but old habits died hard.

And you couldn't blindly trust technology, anyway. Certainly not when fighting someone like Ba'al. Those chips… He glanced back to where Teal'c was literally dragging the bound, gagged and mutilated prisoners and grimaced. Technically, it wasn't a war crime to subdue prisoners who were attacking you, and they hadn't killed them, and they could be healed by Adora - would be healed; it was Adora, after all - but he still felt bad about it.

And speaking of Adora, they were close to the bridge section now. On the HUD, He could see a group of Clones gathered at a junction ahead of them, blocking the access corridor to and from the bridge in this part of the frigate.

Or trying to. Jack scoffed and used his communicator. "Bridge Team? We're almost there. But we could use a little help clearing the way.

"Coming, Crew Quarters!"

Adora must have been tracking them on her own HUD - she charged straight out of the bridge, at the blocking force. Jack heard shots from ahead of him and through the communicator, followed by screams and then the sound of people hitting walls.

By the time his team reached the junction, it was already over. Adora stood in the centre, surrounded by the bodies of the Clones she had just laid out.

Two were groaning, and Jack stunned them with his zat. Better safe than sorry. "We've got the prisoners, but they're in bad shape," he told her with a grimace.

She nodded curtly. "They don't stop fighting. Get on the bridge and cover Entrapta. I'll finish the rest."

Meaning, she wanted to head to Catra, who had taken on the entire hangar section according to the HUD feed. But Jack didn't comment - he understood the feeling, and it made sense for Adora to go and finish the take-over of the ship before they dropped out of hyperspace.

“Alright,” he replied.

Adora nodded once, then ran off while Jack led his team onto the bridge.

“Hi, Jack!” Entrapta waved from the corner. She was sitting, surrounded - and almost hidden - by panels Adora must have ripped off the walls and slammed into the floor to form a barricade. “We're almost at our destination!”

Carter joined her at once, crouching next to Entrapta, and put her computer down.

Jack glanced at the consoles, half of them broken, one with a Clone still stuck in it. That was a bit more damage than he had expected.

“Oh, don't worry - I’m running the ship through my multitool!”

Now Jack was worrying. But Carter didn't seem to mind the setup, so it probably was safe.

“How much longer do we have?” he asked.

“Two minutes, sir.”

Long enough for things to go wrong. He checked the prisoners on the bridge. All but the chipped ones were stunned and wouldn't be a problem. But the chipped ones… the two on the bridge were wrapped in wall panels and still trying to get out - they were tearing themselves bloody in the process. The three Teal'c just set down next to them were worse off, though. “We really need to hack the chips,” he muttered. “Keep an eye on them, Teal'c,” he added.

His friend nodded, and Jack went to the main door to the bridge to stand guard.

The corridor was clear, and he didn't see any Clones moving towards him on the HUD. Not many were moving at all in the ship

- Adora had gone through two gathered groups and was now about to reach the hangar.

“Oh, look - they're trying to manually remove the locks from the main batteries!”

“That won't help them when we cut the power supply.”

“But we can't shut down the reactor.”

“We can manually mark the power lines as under maintenance, that will make the system cut them off.”

“They could bypass it manually. But they would have to move to the engine room for that. Unless they try to siphon power from the life support systems in the section.”

“That won't be enough to power even one beam cannon.”

“But they could charge it in advance - it would give them one shot, at least.”

“We'll be out of hyperspace and being boarded by then.”

“Oh, yes - never mind then. So, this should be safe. Let's start on hacking the mind-control network, then!”

Jack felt a bit better. It sounded as if things were on track. At least on the bridge. They might still pull off this - taking an entire ship with just two teams. Jack would have to make sure that the idiots back on Earth wouldn't try to use that to implement boarding as a standard tactic for fleet engagements. The crayon-eaters would jump at the idea, and some of the Navy pukes might support them even though they should know better.

“Leaving hyperspace in five… four… three…”

Jack tensed.

“...two… one…”

The ship lurched.

*****

Near Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...one…"

Adora was just about to hit the hangar when the ship dropped out of hyperspace - and not as smoothly as she expected - she did stumble at the unexpected movement. But no alarms were going off, and she didn't hear anything breaking, so she continued, using her sword to cut a way into the hangar, where Catra was…

…apparently just finishing off the last resistance, she realised when she came to a stop. "Catra!"

"Hey, Adora!" Her love turned toward her with that sly smile on her face that never failed to make Adora feel that little bit special. Though the fact that Catra's spacesuit was splattered with blood - and her hands and feet were practically covered with it - was a bit distracting.

Catra must have noticed and shrugged. "Most aren't dead, and they weren't able to send out any fighters - or use them to blow the ship up from inside."

Adora took a look at the bodies around Catra. They looked as bloody as Catra did, though she could see most of them breathing and heard them groaning. They needed first aid as well - they were now prisoners of war, with all that entailed. "Good," she said after a moment, then checked the most urgent-looking wounded to heal them.

Catra flexed her hands, extending and retracting her claws several times. Cleaning them using the sealing mechanism Entrapta had built into her suit.

Adora frowned a little. At least, Catra wasn't trying to lick them.

"We've hailed the task force left behind here. Marines are on the way," Jack reported over the communicator.

"Better late than never," Catra commented.

"We were supposed to go on a recon mission," Adora defended them. "We decided to board and take over the enemy flagship without telling them."

"I'm still going to rub it in if they try to act as if they're saving us," Catra said.

"I doubt anyone will claim they saved us if they see this," Adora replied with a nod and a grimace at the pile of bodies.

Catra shrugged. "Marines will."

"Those are Royal Marines," Adora pointed out. "Not US Marines."

"They probably still eat crayons, just the yellow ones." Catra smirked.

Adora shook her head. Her love and Jack got on a bit too well. "Let's clear the space for their shuttles."

"*I* can't throw fighters around."

"You can drag the bodies out of the way!"

Catra snorted but didn't complain any further, and Adora started pushing the fighters into a corner. Assault shuttles needed more room to land under combat conditions.

Catra had just set down the last Clone and was tying up some bandages around the still-bleeding wrist she had sliced when the first shuttle arrived.

Adora used her sword to guide them inside, and as soon as the shuttle touched down, the ramp dropped, and the marines poured out.

“We need to secure the engineering section and the bridge and relieve our teams there before you sweep the ship,” Adora told the commander. “And our prisoners need to be treated and prepared for transport. But check them for chips implanted at the neck. If you find any, call us - those chips can force them to fight with broken limbs and even unconscious.”

“Yes, Supreme Commander!” The captain in charge looked grim as he nodded and started sending out his troops.

“Medics over here!” Catra yelled, and a few soldiers hurried over towards her.

The second assault shuttle touched down as the first soldiers left the hangar, and Adora and Catra left with them to return to the bridge. She tried to ignore the cursing of the medics and other soldiers attending the wounded and frowned at Catra when she heard her snickering at some of the ‘murder-blender’ comments.

Sometimes, Catra's sense of humour was a bit too dark.

*****

Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

The battle was still going on when they reached Point Velvet on board the Horde frigate they had commandeered. Adora stared at the holoprojection on the bridge and frowned. Between the jamming fields - although as happened before, the enemy was compensating by using local direct radio transmission to form a comm network - and the numerical superiority, Ba’al's guard force should not be putting up such resistance. They were losing, that much was obvious, but they were fighting much harder than before. And the task force was taking casualties as a result. So far, they hadn’t lost many ships, but they could only shift the ships around, replacing damaged ones with ships still fit to fight for only so long before they had to send in damaged ones to relieve even more damaged ones, and then the losses would be mounting quickly.

“We need to crash the chips,” Catra said, sounding as grim as Adora felt.

“Yes.”

“We're working on it!” Entrapta called out from where Sam and she had put up their computers. “But it's tricky. Ba'al's been meddling with the software.”

“And he's using non-standard encryption,” Sam added. “It’s not based on any known Goa'uld systems.”

That was not good. If Ba'al was using unknown technology… “Is it related to the datacube's technology?” Adora asked.

“Possibly. We can't tell yet. There are similarities, but we need more data to tell if those are just the result of using the same base principles or actual derivative technology,” Sam replied.

“Just do your best,” Adora told them while she watched another frigate from the task force fall out of formation, the icon lighting up with red alert messages. They were pushing the enemy back - the first factory ships had been disabled - but the Glove was still holding in the centre of the enemy formation.

They needed those chips disabled.

*****

Samantha Carter tried to ignore the space battle raging nearby and focus on the chip network - which must be piggy-backing on the short-range radio network the enemy was using to counter the subspace-jamming attack of the Alliance forces - but each time a chip went offline, she was reminded that that meant, most likely, a destroyed enemy ship. Worse, though, was the effect it had on Entrapta and her efforts to hack the chips.

“The network adapted again!” Entrapta commented. “The distribution changed - and the codes changed.”

The network wasn't using the same architecture as the Alliance networks, based on the Internet. When a member dropped out, data traffic didn't automatically reroute through existing lines and connections to compensate, such as the enemy fleet did - the whole chip network was reorganised, with key nodes changing and even protocols switching.

“This is completely different from the way Horde Prime used them!” her friend went on. “The hardware is the same, but the software… it's totally unlike the software used in the Horde. But! It's not… it's like…” Entrapta shook her head while her hair tendrils kept using two keyboards at once. “The mind-control chips didn't network like that - couldn't network like that.”

“Yes,” Sam agreed. “The way the protocols change, data traffic spikes. Whole new sets of protocols must be transferred each time. We need to decrypt them so we can hack into that.” Once they were inside, they would get the new protocols each time the network shifted.

But the encryption was proving to be frustratingly hard to crack. Sam had no hard proof, but she was certain that it was based on that alien cube's encryption. If only they had cracked that cube earlier…

“Oh, look at that!” Entrapta highlighted a change in data traffic on the holoprojection between them.

Sam narrowed her eyes. The way the shift happened… She couldn't read the data, but the volume… “It's not just temporary spikes when the network shifts - it's forming a new central node each time they shift and they shift all the time.”

“Yes. Even though distributing data through direct connections would be more efficient, that's how the normal communication of the fleet works; they send everything through that node - which keeps shifting around even without a chip dropping off the network. But why does it do that?” Entrapta asked. “It’s

inefficient. It's putting a strain on the network in the middle of all this!”

Sam agreed. It made no sense. It was taking over a lot of the capacity of the enemy fleet's local communication network, and that impacted their performance. She blinked. Performance! “Can the chips actually handle that sort of strain?”

Entrapta gasped and several holographic screens popped up, data scrolling over all of them. Construction materials, internal architecture, everything about the chips. “A regular mind-control chip can't handle that much data - not for long! Not without burning out!”

“They have to keep shifting the central node around to avoid burning out the chips it controls!” Sam shook her head. “If we can stop the transfer…”

“Or if we overload it!” Entrapta nodded. “But how?”

“We can't jam the radio network,” Sam said. The enemy ships were too close and putting out too much power; Alliance ships would have to be far too close to stop that. And jamming drones or bots lacked the sheer power needed for that.

“And we're already jamming the subspace communications,” Entrapta added. “Too bad we can't lure the node into our captured chips and…” She blinked.

Sam drew a sharp breath. They had the chips - and they were set up to receive such data. If they tapped the captured chips into the radio network, waited until a node formed in one of them - the data traffic pattern would show it - and then cut the network before the node could move on… “If the chips don't have backup control nodes, that might do it.”

“If they had such nodes, they wouldn't need to shift around like that and probably could use external cores to run the nodes!” Entrapta nodded eagerly.

But the prisoners with the chips were not here - they had stayed with the captured flagship.

“We need a stealth shuttle and the chipped prisoners!” Sam yelled. “Hurry!”

*****

Their plan had an unexpected drawback, Samantha Carter realised a bit later, in the hangar, waiting for the prisoner transport to arrive. In order to tap into the enemy radio network, they had to get into the enemy formation in a stealth shuttle.

And that required a pilot. Or a crew.

“I'm going, and you're not, and that's final.”

“Jack!”

“Sha're! Listen to him!”

“Why, Daniel? You never do it if you think you're right! He needs a copilot!”

“No, I don't. I can handle a short flight alone. I just need someone to keep an eye on the prisoners. No one else.”

Sam cleared her throat. “I'll have to come as well,” she told the General. “We can't risk the lag from remote operations. Not with subspace still jammed. And if we stop the jamming, the plan will fail.”

He glared at her but had no answer to that and finally, reluctantly and with ill grace nodded.

Good. Sam knew the risk this plan entailed, and she wouldn't send anyone off if she wasn't going as well.

“I should come as well!”

Of course, just because Sam was going didn't mean Entrapta had to go as well. Quite the contrary. It might be hypocritical of her, but she wouldn't let her friend risk her life when it wasn’t necessary for both of them to go.

No matter how much Entrapta pouted.

It had been hard enough to keep Adora from coming along. Sam suspected that she was still trying to find a good argument to go on the mission.

That prisoner transport couldn't come fast enough!

*****

“Pearl Jam en route.”

Samantha Carter ran a last check on the computers she’d set up inside the shuttle, next to the hastily placed prisoner pods - a fancy designation for coffins with life support and medical sensors. But it was necessary to keep the prisoners from trying to attack everyone else - and harming themselves in the process. Even now, with the shuttle's engines accelerating at max power, she could hear some of the chipped Clones bang against the inside of their prisons, and she thought she heard Mal'ak trying to chew through his gag.

It made her feel sick. They needed a quick way to remove such chips, and they needed it yesterday - they couldn't hold enemies with such chips as prisoners without violating the laws of war and every civilised country.

She glanced at the holoprojection to her left, which showed an overview of the battle. The numbers of engaged ships on both sides had shrunk, but not decisively. The task force didn't have the numerical superiority to force a close-quarters engagement, not without taking crippling losses, so they were forced to attempt the now familiar high-speed attacks to create and exploit any weaknesses in the enemy's formation. But since that tactic relied on crippling the enemy's ability to react to sudden changes to be

most effective, and the best they could manage now was to slow Ba'al's fleet down, it was going slowly, and while each individual exchange left the enemy more damaged than the Alliance ships, it still took a steady toll.

But the enemy was hanging by a thread, and Sam and her friends were about to cut that thread - if their plan succeeded.

She pressed her lips together as she watched the shuttle's course on the holoprojection, swinging around the most recent attack by an ad-hoc squadron on the enemy formation to avoid stray beam cannon volleys. A single hit would destroy the shuttle at once.

She forced the thought away and checked her setup again. The radio connections were ready, the routines to cut the connection the moment the data had spiked as well, and the power supply was holding steady.

“How are the prisoners doing?” the General asked.

“Their status remains unchanged, O'Neill,” Teal'c replied in the same tone he used when talking about the weather. Unflappable and dependable - and deadly, as usual.

“And the tech stuff, Carter?”

“Everything's ready, sir.” She sounded a bit clipped, she realised, but he didn't comment on it.

“Alright, we're going in. I've picked out a nice frigate in the back. Keep those radio receivers peeled so we don't have to bump into the enemy hull to get a reception!”

She snorted at the weak joke as she checked the holoprojection again - they were headed straight for a frigate in the rear part - but since the enemy was surrounded, that meant they had to pass through the enemy line.

“Starting evasive flying,” the General announced a moment later, and the shuttle began to juke and weave - on the holoprojection;

Sam didn't feel any movement through the ship's inertial compensator.

To their side, another ad-hoc squadron was launching a fly-by attack, and a few seconds later, the enemy shifted in response. That opened a hole for the shuttle - and the enemy fire would be aimed away from them.

But now they were in radio range, and Sam connected the setup to the receivers. “Trap active,” she reported.

They passed so close to an enemy frigate, badly damaged but still flying, that Sam could see it through the cockpit's windows - and its guns firing - but there was no data spike. The control side might not want to switch to a frontline ship, she thought.

Then they were through the enemy line and headed to the enemy rear - or centre, depending on your view. The radio traffic was heavier here, and she saw another data spike on the chip network - yet not to the trap. Could they locate the chips through the radio network? If they could, they would be able to find the shuttle despite the stealth field, but it should be impossible in such a dense formation while using high-powered short-range radio signals in the middle of massive jamming. And the chips were not connected to the regular communications, as far as they knew, so they couldn't use that to feed targeting data to the beam cannons. But Ba'al had surprised them before…

But no ship turned their weapons on them even as the prisoners’ chips connected to the network. Maybe Entrapta's theory was correct and the chips could only enforce loyalty and a berserker mode and lacked the capacity to take over a body like a Goa'uld could? Or was that what the control node could do?

They wouldn't be able to tell until they had the time to analyse them properly.

“We're flying around their flagship. Anyone biting?”

“Not yet, sir. There are many chips for the control node to switch to, and if it's random then this could take a bit,” Sam told the General. He knew that already - she had briefed everyone on the risks. But flying so closely to the enemy - the shuttle's icon almost disappeared under the enemy icon on the holoprojection - would stress anyone.

She glanced at the prisoner pods again, No change. What if she had miscalculated? What if the chips were blocked from rejoining the network if they went offline? No, that would have crashed the entire network when the jammers started, but there could be security protocols that delayed…

The computer alert went off - data spike! A moment later, the second alert went off. “Data spike! Trap offline!” she reported. “Checking reaction!”

The logs showed the data spike - into Mal'ak. And the connection was cut before any other data spike could be registered. The control node had been severed!

She smiled, showing her teeth, as she sent the confirmation to Entrapta and started hacking the chips’ network. Without the control node refreshing and changing the protocols every few seconds, they could finally finish this!

Then Mal'ak's medical sensors started to scream alerts - his chip was literally burning out!

*****

Ba’al’s Machinations Part 9

Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Mal’ak’s chip’s burning out. It’s affecting his brain.

Catra drew a sharp breath when she received Sam’s report - passed as a message through the Alliance network to bypass the area-jamming focused on the enemy fleet. Her own chip had burnt out as well, but she hadn’t been hurt like that. What was going on? What had Ba’al done with the chips? The hardware was supposed to be the same as Horde Prime’s chips!

“Oh, no!” Adora exclaimed.

Catra checked the shuttle’s position. It was still inside the enemy formation, close to the centre. If they made a run for it without another attack by Alliance forces opening a hole to slip through, they’d risk getting caught by a stray volley - from either side. “They can’t escape until they’ve hacked the chips.”

“Almost done!” Entrapta yelled from her corner of the bridge. “Without the control node switching things around every few seconds, it’s just a modified version of Horde Prime’s programs, and I know those, well, I knew them - they’ve adapted some, but they’re not really adaptive, so it’s not a mutating system, but… Here we go! Crashing the chips!”

For the first few seconds, nothing happened. Part of that was signal lag - they had to go through the enemy radio network - but part of that was that even if you took out the captain of an enemy ship, the crew would keep going.

But as Catra watched, she saw the first signs of the enemy formation falling apart - slowly but surely, the coordination that had kept the ships together faded, and the formation became frayed, tattered at the edges. Replacing captains in the middle of a fight was never a smooth operation, and if the replacements

lacked the mind control chips, they wouldn't really be able to keep up as before.

Here, a ship was a bit too slow to react to an Alliance squadron's fly-by attack, getting caught outside the cover provided by the rest of the ships nearby. There, a frigate retreated a bit too far from another probing attack, escaping any harm but opening a hole in the defence that exposed two more to withering fire from another squadron. And two ships suddenly turned and tried to flee.

Tried. One was shot down by another frigate as it passed, and the other veered off course, weaving back and forth and alternating speed - directly into the Alliance right wing. "Must have been mutineers," she whispered as the ship was disabled - almost broken in two - when their engines were destroyed by massed fire.

And Jack must have seen an opportunity - or just grown desperate - since the shuttle was hightailing it out of the enemy formation now. Catra held her breath as it flew straight at a defensive formation of enemy frigates, but it took a sharp turn before entering their area and flew underneath them, transponder flaring, towards the Alliance line.

She released her breath when the shuttle was safely behind their frontline and turned to Adora. "We have to push now. When they are at their most vulnerable. Before they restore the chain of command. If we can break them now, the battle's over." But if they didn't, they'd take losses they wouldn't take if they just kept whittling down the enemy numbers.

Adora knew that as well. She pressed her lips together for a moment, then nodded. "Captain, signal the task force to press the attack."

"Yes, Supreme Commander!"

On the holographic projection, the Alliance forces shifted, more reserves called forth as the more damaged ships were left behind, and the lightly damaged ones took point. Catra could see the enemy's formation trying to adapt to the attack they knew was coming, but their chain of command would still be dealing with losing all commanders at the same time, and even for the Clones, that was a huge blow.

Instead of an all-out attack, the Alliance fleet attacked by sections. One section, composed of all the ships in the best state, smashed straight into the enemy formation. And when the enemy centre fell back, the outer parts found themselves enveloping the section but also exposed to the next attacks, which cut through them before they could decimate the first wave.

Four, five enemy ships - half of them not even engaged - turned at that moment. One was shot down by their own group, the others ended up charging straight at another Alliance formation.

Three were wrecked in short order, the last one turned so hard, it flew through another squadron of Ba'al's frigates, almost ramming one as it thoroughly dissolved their formation.

The Alliance forces pounced on the ships left in disarray, and as they quickly died, isolated and without coordination and cover, a hole opened in the enemy formation through which two, three Alliance squadrons pushed.

"It's over," Catra said. The enemy formation was falling apart in front of her eyes. Ships fought by themselves, all coordination lost, as the Alliance frigates quickly focused their fire on one enemy after the other. And with every enemy frigate destroyed, the Alliance's advantage in numbers grew.

A few minutes later, the last handful of enemy frigates were drifting in space trailed by debris or turned into expanding clouds of plasma.

And Jack's shuttle landed on their ship.

*****

Jack O'Neill was very grateful that the life support system of the stealth shuttle was rated for heavy duty; thanks to the filters in the ventilation system, he had barely caught a whiff of the stench of burning skin and flesh from the shuttle's cargo area.

He had heard the noise Ba'al's First Prime had made, even through his gag, when the chip had started burning. It was a good thing that the Alliance navy wasn't a dry navy - at least not the Clone ships - since Jack really needed a drink right now. Unfortunately, he would have to wait until he had landed the shuttle and dealt with the entire mess.

At least, they were ready for them; he saw a medical team waiting with a floating gurney as he guided the shuttle into the frigate's hangar, and as soon as he touched down, the four Clones were rushing to the back of the shuttle.

Jack lowered the ramp and got up. "We've arrived, folks." He almost added: 'Thank you for flying O'Neill Air', but Carter looked too grim to appreciate the joke. "How's the prisoner doing?"

"He's alive," Carter replied as she got up and let the medics grab Mal'ak. "But I can't tell yet what neural damage he suffered."

Jack winced. "I didn't think the chips were supposed to do that - didn't Catra mention that her own had burnt out as well?"

"They aren't supposed to do that," Carter replied in a clipped tone. "And the hardware is the same. Ba'al must have managed to alter the software in a way that allows it to overheat the chip to the point of burning the flesh it's attached to."

"The pain from burning skin should not have caused such a reaction," Teal'c spoke up. "If he could not take molten gold poured into Ba'al's symbol carved into his forehead without flinching, he would not have become Ba'al's First Prime."

Yeah, Jack wasn't about to comment on that. Or glance at the golden symbol on Teal'c's forehead.

"Yes," Carter said. "That's why I suspect that the chip did something to his brain."

"Something more painful than burning." Jack pressed his lips together. "Cooking the brain?"

Carter frowned. "That is not physically possible with the chip, sir."

Learned a new thing.

The Clones had finished loading the trembling - and bound - Jaffa on the gurney and were taking him out of the shuttle. He was no longer Jack's responsibility. Not officially, at least. But Jack had been in charge of the mission - he had carried a prisoner of war into battle to use them against the enemy. Even if Mal'ak hadn't been hurt, that would've been sketchy. Now? Jack was sure there would be an investigation. And 'I was following orders' wouldn't cut it. Not that he'd use that excuse - he had known what he was doing when he had taken command.

*****

"What? A war crime?"

Jack nodded. "Yes. Prisoners of war aren't supposed to be sent into danger like that."

"But…" Adora blinked. "Oh, no! I didn't think of that!"

"It was my plan, sir," Carter spoke up. "My responsibility."

"I was in charge of the mission, Major" Jack retorted. If anyone had to take the fall for this, it would be him.

"I'm the Supreme Commander of the Alliance, and I approved of this. If anyone is to blame, it's me." Adora glared at both of them.

“Who’s going to prosecute you? You’re She-Ra, Princess of Power,” Glimmer said. “And the Supreme Commander of the Alliance.”

Adora’s glare switched targets. “I’m not going to hide behind that!”

Ah… Jack winced. That wasn’t going how he thought it would be going.

“You’re a Princess; you have diplomatic immunity,” Glimmer shot back. “Besides, what do you think will happen if some idiot tries to punish you for this? Priest will nod along?”

“I’ll tell him that I was wrong.”

“You weren’t wrong,” Catra spoke up. “The chips were already hurting the prisoners - they almost killed themselves. This was the only way we saw to hack them and stop them.” She flashed her fangs. “Call it emergency medical aid.”

That was… certainly creative. Jack didn’t think too many prosecutors would agree, though that would likely not matter - it might be a good enough excuse to sweep this under the rug.

“But…” Adora tried to defend herself - or the opposite.

Catra shook her head. “We had no choice. If we wanted to save the chipped people, we had to hack those chips. And Mal’ak was Ba’al’s First Prime - hardly an innocent victim.”

Jack glanced at Teal’c. His friend had been Apophis’s First Prime and had deserted. But Teal’c didn’t say anything nor showed any expression.

And Carter looked torn.

“Still, we’re not supposed to treat prisoners like that!” Adora said.

Catra shrugged. “Not even to save them?” She scoffed. “Those chips had to be hacked. We couldn’t let them be mind-controlled.

And that was the only way.”

At least, they hadn’t been able to think of a better way at the moment, Jack amended the statement in his head. But it was better to get on with the program. “So… we tried to save them, and the only way that seemed to offer any hope was dangerous but worked - in the end.” Well, he had done worse in the past, and it had been buried.

But as everyone nodded, more or less reluctantly, Jack couldn’t help feeling as if he were a spook. Or a politician.

*****

Ba’al’s Glove, Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Adora watched on the HUD as the royal marines went through another section of the ship. They had already scanned for ambushes and bombs - Adora herself had taken down a squad of Jaffa trying to hold a chokepoint - but the soldiers still proceeded cautiously through the corridors.

“They're fine,” Catra commented behind her.

Adora knew that. But she still worried. They were acting on her orders - and as she had just been pointed out to her, she wasn't perfect. To think she had broken the laws of war!

“We've collected all the chipped people already,” Catra went on. “This is just standard procedure.”

Adora glanced at her. “What about the prisoners?”

“None of them show any symptoms like Mal'ak does,” Catra replied. “Sam and Entrapta are removing the chips as fast as they can.”

That was good. Adora felt guilty already for subjecting Mal'ak to this ordeal. They should have considered the risk and taken the

chip out before heading in. But the chip wouldn't have linked up with the network if it hadn't been implanted, and… She clenched her teeth. It wasn't an excuse.

"We did what we could and had to," Catra said. "We couldn't let this go on."

Adora pressed her lips together. The excuse rang hollow. They shouldn't have used a prisoner like that. But they shouldn't have let the chipped people suffer longer either… There was no good answer. They just had to do better - much better - next time. "What are their reactions?"

Catra made a scoffing noise. "What do you think? They are traumatised by the experience."

Like Catra had been. Like any host of a Goa'uld had been.

Adora still had to ask. No two people were alike, not even Clones. Some might fool themselves into thinking they deserved to be controlled like that. And some might even consider it an honour. They didn't know what Mal'ak thought about it - the former First Prime of Ba'al still wasn't able to be interrogated.

"They're getting treatment," Catra went on. "We're doing what we can. But we need to find the chip factory and destroy it."

Adora nodded. That, at least, was clear and obvious. "We need to decide what we do about this site," she said. "Ba'al could already be massing ships to attack us."

"He can't just keep counter-attacking - we've defeated every force of his we've met so far," Catra said. "At some point, he has to start worrying about his remaining assets."

"We don't know how many forces he has left," Adora pointed out. It was unlikely that Ba'al could have enough Horde forces to match the Alliance, but not technically impossible.

Catra scoffed again. “If he had enough advanced forces to match us, he'd have done so straight away. He wouldn't have sent half a dozen frigates with a fleet of barely-upgraded Ha'taks after us. And he would have reinforced this site with more ships.”

Adora nodded. It was likely that they had destroyed the bulk of the Horde forces that had joined Ba'al. But they couldn't be sure until they knew what forces Ba'al had left. “We need more intel.”

“No shit!” Catra growled under her breath. “But the only one who seems to know everything is Ba'al himself. Either we take him out, or we have to wait until our spy bot network is covering the entire sector.”

And even then, they couldn't be sure Ba'al wouldn't have some hidden base or yard in another part of the galaxy. This site wasn't in a system, after all - they would have missed it if they had simply mapped all systems in the area. “We still have half the spy bots tracking their ships,” Adora said. “But we need to decide whether we hold this site or move everything back to the Alliance.”

“Whether we abandon the Glove or not, you mean,” Catra replied.

“Yes.” They could evacuate everything else, but the unfinished flagship didn't have any engines yet. And while it was far from being finished, it was already too big to be moved by anything the task force had access to.

“We don't need it,” Catra said. “It would take far too long to finish it, and even if we did finish it, we don't need a ship that big. Not to mention that it would send a pretty bad message to half of Etheria and any survivors of Horde Prime's campaigns.”

She was correct, of course - Adora didn't think anyone who had fought Horde Prime would want to see his flagship again. The Velvet Glove had been responsible for so much destruction in the galaxy. “Some people will be angry,” she said. Some people would

love to have the biggest ship in the sector. And access to the factories planned to be built into it.

"Let them." Cara shrugged. "It would be a bad idea to focus so much into one ship, anyway. As Ba'al just found out."

Adora agreed with that. Not just because they couldn't afford to lose such a ship but also because whoever controlled the ship would control a lot of the Alliance's fleet strength. And that would influence Alliance politics. Still… "Let's discuss it with the others."

Catra shrugged. "I don't think Glimmer will disagree."

Adora didn't think so either. Jack was a wild card, though.

*****

Point Velvet, Deep Space, July 5th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Samantha Carter suppressed a yawn as she stared at the latest data points from the analysis. The central control node code had to have protocols to link up with a higher authority - anything else wouldn't let Ba'al update the standing orders. And there would have to be checks and tests to validate such orders - data the Alliance could use against Ba'al, even if it wouldn't deliver them the coordinates of another of Ba'al's bases.

Unfortunately, after trapping the control node in Mal'ak's chip - Sam's lips formed a thin line when she remembered the consequences of that decision - it had started to burn out, and so they had barely managed to recover fragments of the code before the chip had died and almost taken Mal'ak with it. All that crucial data lost…

"Alright. I think I've finished restoring that piece of code," Entrapta said. "The advanced control routines would work according to the simulation, though we haven't tested that yet so it's not yet confirmed by empirical data."

“Uh, which won't happen because the Alliance doesn't mind-control people,” Bow pointed out.

“Right! Of course!” Entrapta nodded.

Sam focused on the new data. The subroutines to control the carriers were the same as Horde Prime's - they had confirmed that with data from all the chips that they had captured - but anything about the actual advanced control node's directives and decision trees were assumptions. Assumptions based on the data from those chips which had hosted the control node during the battle detailing the orders and changes in behaviour it had left.

And wasn't that a nice, clinical way to talk and think about a chip warping a person's innermost thoughts and desires?

“At least we've managed to streamline the removal of the chips,” Bow said after a few moments.

That hadn't taken much beyond Entrapta and Bow remembering how they had dealt with Horde Prime's chips and checking if the basic methods worked. Sam still nodded since it meant all of the chips’ victims were now free. Traumatised and in need of help but no longer trapped in their own bodies - or, worse, mentally manipulated to become fanatical followers of Ba'al.

But it had netted them a lot of chips to analyse, which they had been doing for hours. Every little detail, every data point, could add up and allow them to crack Ba'al’s defences.

Sam would be more optimistic if she couldn't think of half a dozen ways to avoid any potential weakness she came up with. No one is perfect, certainly not someone as egoistical as Ba'al, she told herself. He has to have made a mistake; we just need to find it.

The key was the floating control node's code. All of Ba'al's orders had run through that; updating the network chip after chip as it jumped around. All the protocols and data would have been concentrated there - and gone when the last host chip had burnt out. Something Ba'al had likely intended.

But it was also an obvious failure point and a weakness. Take out the control node, as Sam and her friends had done, and the whole network collapsed. Any chip that survived wouldn't have any way to safely link up with another network. No protocols to validate sources and update orders.

Ba'al did like to compartmentalise his forces. Maybe he preferred to write off a network if it lost the central node? Fighting to the death was certainly standard operation procedure for his followers.

But Sam didn't think that Ba'al would go as far as to permanently split up his forces from the start. And even so, he couldn't expect to keep all chips in a network together forever - ships were sent out on scouting missions all the time, task forces split up according to the needs of any given mission, courier work was fairly common and would require the kind of loyalty mind-control chips enforced. So, every chip had to have a way to rejoin a network. Anything else wouldn't make any sense, not even for a paranoid Goa'uld. Protocols to establish contact. Validate signals. Accept new directives. Everything you needed to become part of the network - or infiltrate it.

Sam and her friends just had to find those protocols in the core software of the chips. But they had been sifting the entire code for any trace of such protocols and had only found the routines that handled the technical parts. Not the ones that actually authorised such link-ups. Where had Ba'al hidden them?

Even simulating a network connection didn't reveal them - the chips linked up, but nothing past signal testing data was exchanged. No actual data; it was like the higher functions were missing…

Sam blinked. "Oh, of course!"

Ba'al was a Goa'uld. Goa'uld were parasites, sapient, but they depended on the brains of their hosts to achieve their full intellectual potential. And what use would a chip without a carrier

be for any network? It would feel natural for him to link - to outsource - core network functions to a chip carrier's brain, wouldn't it?

“Can we fool a chip into believing that they are hooked up to a brain?” she asked, then groaned at the realisation that she was starting to anthropomise chips.

“We could, I think, but why?” Bow said.

Sam explained.

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“...and so we confirmed that the chips use part of the carrier's brain to store data, presumably crucial parts such as network protocols and valuation codes.”

Catra felt the fur at the back of her neck bristle at Sam's briefing. Those damned chips not only took over your body - forcing it to keep fighting even when you were unconscious or dead - but they used your brain for data storage? She'd personally kill whoever came up with this.

“That's…” Even Jack didn't seem to have a joke ready.

“That's horrible!” Glimmer spat.

“Can we fix that?” Adora's expression sent a cold shiver down Catra's spine. She hadn't seen her love looking grim like that very often. “Give people back their… brains?”

Sam winced. “We're still examining the victims. So far, we have not yet been able to access the data stored in their brains, though we’re working on identifying and duplicating the protocols in the chips. Once we can assess the scope of the changes to the brain, it should be possible to ascertain what was done to them.”

In other words, they didn't know and were not optimistic. “So… We can't exclude the possibility that those parts of their brain

contain some ways to mind-control the victims?” Catra asked.

“Shit!” Jack cursed. “Sleeper agent protocols?”

“We can't exclude that possibility at this point,” Sam confirmed.

“I can try healing them,” Adora said. “This… I should be able to restore someone’s brain to their control.”

Catra wasn't so certain, but she didn't think it would hurt to try. Though if it took She-Ra to deal with this, that would be another burden on her love.

“We'll have to examine the victims more thoroughly first, to establish a baseline,” Sam said.

“Yeah! Or we might not be able to tell what your magic is doing to people's brains,” Entrapta added. “We don't know yet what the chip did to brains - not in detail.”

“It's a very complicated interface,” Bow cut in. “We first thought it was merely an, ah, alternate way to safely store data, protect it from access through conventional means, but the chips' protocols are too complex for that. It doesn’t help that we can't use the chips directly to access the data.”

Catra glanced around, half-expecting someone to ask why they couldn't put a mind-control chip back into a victim to check their brain, but to her relief, no one was that stupid.

“Alright.” Adora nodded. “Keep working on that - it takes priority. We need all the information about those chips we can get to stop Ba'al. Now, next item: The state of this site and our task force.”

That was her cue. Sort of. Catra sat straighter and pulled her tablet out. “We're still recovering from the battle, but we've used the captured facilities here to repair our ships. A third of the task force's frigates have been restored to full combat readiness, and another third, while still showing damaged secondary systems, have had their shields, engines and main batteries repaired. The

last third, though, will require lengthier stays in docks, either here or in facilities behind our lines."

"We lost a third of our task force, then." Jack didn't sound happy.

"Temporarily," Glimmer said. "They will be repaired."

"That still will cost us resources that could go into building new ships," Catra pointed out. Glimmer frowned at her, but she shrugged. "Opportunity costs are still costs. At least the casualties were light." Trained and especially experienced crew was much harder to replace than ships, after all.

"We were lucky there," Adora said. "If the battle had continued a bit longer, we would have been forced to field even more damaged ships, and losses and casualties would have rapidly grown."

Yeah. As long as you could shift ships around to spread the damage taken by the enemy, you could avoid heavy losses, but once you ran out of undamaged ships to rotate into the frontlines, damage would accumulate fast. Catra had seen it happen in the Horde war with ground units. Once a unit had taken so many casualties that it started to break, you could write it off.

"So… we're basically at half effectiveness," Jack summed up.

"Yes. Which means we cannot repel a counter-attack by a force the same size as the force we took down," Adora said. "We need to evacuate the site."

"That would mean leaving the unfinished Glove," Glimmer said.

"No big loss," Catra said. "It's just a chunk of hull at this point. No engine, reactor, shield or weapons of any note. Not even the factories have been completed yet." She shrugged. "Less than a quarter of the entire ship, too."

"What a waste of resources," Jack commented.

“We didn't spend it,” Glimmer said. “Ba’al did.”

“And finishing the ship would require too much time, too many resources, and too many forces to guard this site,” Adora said. “We can't afford it.”

“So, we'll loot it of everything we can take and blow up the rest. Or Have Adora turn it into a space plant,” Catra said, flashing her fangs.

“I can't actually use magic on that scale out here,” Adora said. “I would need a world's restored magic to do that.”

”So, we can't leave a message for Ba’al using flower language. Too bad.” Jack grinned. “I guess some explosives will have to do.”

“And we'll have to pack up the factory ships - and the ships forming their supply lines,” Catra said. “They're slower than frigates, so we better get a move on.” Digesting everything back home would also require an effort. But overall, this should help with Alliance war production capacities.

Once they figured out who got what, of course. Catra had a feeling that this would cause some issues with Earth.

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Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, July 15th, 2000

“...and surely, General, you agree that moving the, ah, liberated production assets of Ba’al to Etheria is a blatant attempt to present the Alliance with a fait accompli that flies in the face of the treaty that formed the Alliance.”

Jack O’Neill resisted the urge to roll his eyes; the Secretary of Defense was, after all, his superior. Sort of - Jack was part of the forces the United States had assigned to the Alliance, and he answered to Adora, but he had not left the Air Force. “Etheria was the closest system under secure Alliance control,” he said. “Moving the captured factory and mining ships anywhere else would have

both required significant forces to guard them and taken far longer. That would have significantly reduced the Alliance's offensive and defensive capabilities in the war." Something the man should have been aware of!

"Yes, yes, I've read the reports." The other man shook his head almost dismissively. "But we can't just look at this from a military point of view, General - we have to take the bigger picture into account. Those factory and yard ships are the most advanced we have; they are geared to produce Horde-style frigates and supporting craft. To place them under the direct control of the Princess Alliance in Etheria when Etheria already controls the factory ships of the Horde fleets in the Alliance seems like an obvious attempt to cement their monopoly on advanced ship production."

Oh for…! Jack shook his head. "The different Clone fleets control their own fleet trains, sir. The Princess Alliance doesn't have control over them."

"Two of the fleets worship She-Ra as their goddess, and the other two are commanded by Princess Entrapta's consort and a very close friend, respectively; I think we can dispense with the polite fiction that the Princess Alliance doesn't control the Horde ships, General."

Jack stared. "Have you met Princess Entrapta?" Did the man honestly believe that Entrapta was some… seductress controlling the Clones through Hordak and WrongHordak?

The man frowned. "Despite her eccentricities, Princess Entrapta is a ruling princess - and one of the oldest members of the Princess Alliance's leadership council, General."

"Entrapta doesn't care about politics; she just cares about technology and her friends," Jack shot back.

"That might be so, but that means she will listen to her friends - and the majority of her friends are members of the Princess

Alliance, General. How often did the Horde leaders oppose any proposal from them?" Before Jack could answer, the man went on: "And even if we would assume that your view was correct, you have to consider the optics, General."

"The optics?" Jack frowned again.

"It's an election year, General. How do you think the American people think about the fact that we still seem to be playing second fiddle to the rest of the Alliance?"

Oh. "I think they're more concerned about the body-snatching evil alien parasites trying to enslave us all, sir."

"You would think so, but that's not what the polls say. People are concerned about being beholden to aliens, period. They haven't forgotten how America was forced to bend to the demands of the Princess Alliance. The American people expect us to be the leading nation of Earth, not the junior partner of an Alliance led by aliens." The Secretary of Defense shook his head. "We're lucky that they arrived two years ago, and the reports from the invasions we launched did help, but the public isn't stupid - they see all those alien ships in the news, they see the British ships in combat - and they don't care that those were glorified feighters - and they ask where the American ships are in this war."

"Well, if they want a strong fleet, maybe the Navy shouldn't be building lemons," Jack retorted. The US frigates were still not rated for combat outside the solar system.

That earned him a glare. "All new designs have teething issues. I am sure those will be soon ironed out - Major Carter is supposed to work hard on them, isn't she? - but we need more production capacity under American control if we want to regain our position."

"And win the election," Jack said in the flattest tone he could manage.

“You don’t change the team in the middle of the game, General. Besides, how do you think the Etherians will react if the US Government is replaced by people who think the gay should go back in the closet?”

Jack hadn’t exactly paid a lot of attention to the election campaigns, but he would have noticed any such demand - hell, the Etherians would have asked him about it! “I don’t believe that the next president, whoever it will be, will change those policies, sir.”

“Of course not! It’s in the constitution now! But the press, especially the foreign press, will dig up everything they said about gays and lesbians in the past in an attempt to cut us off at the knees. We can’t afford that kind of trouble.” The man narrowed his eyes again. “We need to get control of those factory ships before the election, General, so we can show the public that America isn’t weak any more and on the way to regain our place as the leader of the free world.”

“That seems to be a political challenge, sir,” Jack said with all the diplomatic restraint he could muster. “Not a military problem.”

“On this level, that’s the same thing, General.”

“But I’m a military officer, sir.” Not a politician.

“And you’re an American - the highest American officer in the Alliance. A close friend of the core leaders of the Princess Alliance. Your country needs you, General.”

It sounded more as if Jack’s government needed him. “And you want me to… talk to the princesses?”

“I want you to give them your honest appraisal of the danger for the Alliance if the production capacities remain as unbalanced as they currently are, General.”

Fuck.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, Etheria System, July 16th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"What? They want us to move the entire production line to the Solar System?" Adora shook her head. "That makes no sense - that would take months, not including setting up the mining operations to supply the factory ships and yard ships! We've just finished setting up in the Etheria system, and we already had mining infrastructure here!" Moving an entire space-based shipyard complex took a lot of time and effort!

"Against opposition from our resident isolationists," Glimmer added with a scowl. "They claimed to be worried about the effects asteroid mining had on Etheria's magic!"

Jack shrugged with a slight grimace. "The US government is concerned about the upcoming election."

"They're worried that the opposition party might be exploiting the lingering resentment amongst part of the American population that the United States isn't the uncontested superpower on Earth any more," Daniel said. "At least, the polls I've looked into seem to show that this is a view shared by a not insignificant part of the population."

Glimmer muttered something brief and not very complimentary about democracy that Adora chose to ignore. America, and pretty much every Earth country in the Alliance, was a democracy. That wouldn't change. But… "I thought that blatantly using your power as the government to ensure you stayed in power was considered an abuse of power in a democracy."

"Ah…" Daniel grimaced as well. "It's complicated."

"I sense some hypocrisy coming," Catra commented.

"Well, a democratic government is supposed to implement policies to improve the lives of their people, which, in turn, will, if they are

successful, and seen as being successful, gain the voter's support in the next election," Daniel said. "That includes caring about the concerns of the population."

"*Appearing* to care about them, you mean," Catra cut in.

Adora frowned at her. Catra's cynical views of democracy weren't really helpful right now.

Daniel, though, nodded. "Yes. In politics, perception often is more important than reality."

Glimmer muttered something about democracy again.

Adora focused on the actual issue. "And the US government doesn't want to look weak to their voters, which is why they want us to move the Horde fleet train we captured to Earth and hand it over to them."

Jack shrugged again. "More or less. They were a bit cagey about the whole thing."

"We already could tell because they went through you, Jack, and not through official channels," Daniel said.

"The other countries would protest about such a blatant power grab." Glimmer shook her head. "How do they think this would work, anyway? Those yard ships produce Horde frigates. The Americans chose to build their own designs. Do they want to retool the entire line?"

Catra scoffed. "For their crappy designs? Might as well blow the entire line up and save us the waste of resources and crews!"

"That's a bit harsh, I think," Bow said.

"No, it's not. Just listen to Sam rant about them," Catra shot back.

Adora nodded. The many, many problems with the American ships were well-known. "Leaving that aside, would a change of

government really be that bad?”

“Well, if they campaign on more nationalist rhetoric and win, then the new government would likely push for more influence in the Alliance,” Daniel said.

“You mean, they'd ask for the same things the current government does?” Catra snorted again.

“Well…” Daniel spread his hands. “In a way, yes.”

“I don't think we should get involved in that,” Glimmer said. “That feels like meddling in a succession issue in another kingdom.”

“Historically, most succession issues on Etheria involved other kingdoms as well,” Bow pointed out.

“That doesn't mean meddling is a good idea,” Glimmer shot back.

Adora agreed. “Yes. We shouldn't let the internal policies of one country shape the way we conduct this war. Our focus has to be on winning the war against the Goa'uld, not elections.” She was sure the rest of the Council would agree - none of the other NATO countries had struck her as particularly happy with the American leadership.

*****

Spacelab, Earth Orbit, Solar System, July 17th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“OK! That should work! Now let's test it!”

Samantha Carter nodded at Entrapta's comment. The latest version of their brain scanner looked promising. Well, it was more of a brain interface, to be precise. Their scanners were already able to scan brains, but they hadn't been able yet to connect them to Ba'al's chips. Whoever had written the software for those abominations must have been both a genius and utterly deranged.

“Connecting the interface,” she said as she checked once more that the outside connections were cut before powering up the link between the air-gapped scanner and the isolated chip.

“Protocols… engaging,” Entrapta said. “Oh, look - data exchange started.”

That was promising, but they had such successes before. If the chip's protocols were not satisfied, it would… The indicators changed. “Successful connection.”

“It's looking into the data from the scans!”

Yes, the chip was treating the data as if it were live readings from a brain. Or so Sam hoped. If they could fool the chip, they could get at the reading/writing routines, and then they could access the altered parts of the brains of the chipped victims and find out what data was stored there.

That could be the key to cracking the entire network.

Sam leaned forward as the chip's routines started exchanging great amounts of data with their simulated brain.

“Oh, look at that, Sam! It’s trying to alter the brain chemistry! As we theorised!”

Sam nodded. Another piece of the puzzle had been solved. Sooner or later, the whole thing would be open to them.

And then, they could start on tracking down such networks.

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Ba’al’s Machinations Part 10

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, July 18th, 2000

“...and we cannot close our eyes to the fact that we’ve been at this war for years - almost during the entire time the current administration was in power - and yet, America’s position hasn’t improved. We depend on alien protection and alien technology for everything! Should the Alliance break apart, America would be left helpless. This has to change! We cannot depend on others any more!”

“Those were very strong statements. And it’s still two weeks until the national convention - can we expect even stronger statements then, James?”

“I believe so, Julia! The war against the Goa’uld is dominating this election, and the polls all agree that it is a very divisive issue for America. And while Americans are generally loath to change governments in the middle of a war, with the term limits applied, the effect of that sentiment is naturally not as strong as it could be, and many of us remember how quickly the last war was won under President Bush, so…”

Sitting in the meeting room that she usually occupied in the Alliance HQ, Catra rolled her eyes and switched channels. The Gulf War had been fought with tanks and planes, not spaceships, and with overwhelming material superiority. If anyone thought you could wage war the same way in space, they needed a reality check.

“...and this is not merely a question about how to conduct the war against those aliens, but a question that touches the very soul of our nation: Should America become one nation amongst many, or should we continue to be the shining city on the hill, the ideal other nations aspire to become? After the fall of the Soviet Union, America has been the world's uncontested leader. Where we went, others followed. We were the first to step on the moon - and we

were the first to reach out to the stars and strike a blow against the Goa'uld! This is a proud history and a responsibility we cannot discharge as easily as the current government wants us to! America is not one country amongst many, but a promise! So…"

"...and I can only repeat what our government already stated: America cannot stand alone and it should not stand alone. From the beginning, we have been looking for allies against the Goa'uls. We will not reject our friends - we will stand by their side, united against the Goa'uld. America is a strong part of the Alliance, and we will only grow stronger as we adapt the advanced technology shared with us and develop our own. It would be the height of foolishness to…"

Catra turned the TV off.

"That's why democracy is such a stupid system: It's not even been two years since we made the Alliance treaty, and yet, those people want to change it!" Glimmer complained. "How can you trust such a country? Even the worst princesses back home know that you can't just dissolve a treaty like that!"

"Ah, I don't think they want to dissolve the treaty," Bow said. "They just want to, ah, change how Alliance procurement works."

"They want to take control of the shipyards because they can't stand that they aren't the most powerful member of the Alliance!" Glimmer shot back. "Jack told us that - and they're saying it in public!"

Catra nodded in agreement.

"Well, they are going to become the most powerful member of the Alliance once they adapt to advanced technology - they are the biggest country with the strongest economy," Bow pointed out.

"Yes! But that makes this even worse - they don't even have the patience to wait a few years!" Glimmer scoffed. "Don't they know about long-term planning?"

“That won’t win them the next election,” Catra said.

“Short-sighted fools!” Glimmer bared her teeth and crossed her arms with a huff.

“At least the other countries aren’t like that,” Bow tried to smile encouragingly. “And they’re democracies as well.”

Glimmer huffed again. “They would probably act the same if they were as big as the United States.”

“Probably. Except for the Germans,” Catra said.

“Well, yes. But they’re weird about it.” Glimmer shrugged, then sighed. “I just wish they’d focus on beating the snakes instead of each other.”

“It’s not that bad,” Bow objected. “They just… are still adjusting.”

“Then they should adjust more quickly!”

Catra snorted.

“Well, as long as we can keep them from messing up Alliance strategy and production, it won’t matter much who’s in charge of the United States, right?” Bow asked.

“They both want the same anyway,” Glimmer grumbled.

“That’s consistent, at least,” Catra said with a grin. “It’s almost as if America had a princess.”

Glimmer scowled at her, and Bow chuckled politely.

“How much longer until Adora’s back from her meeting?” Glimmer asked after a moment.

Catra shrugged. “It depends on what Priest’s been doing while we were fighting Ba’al. If he’s been good, it shouldn’t take too long.”

“Great. We’ll be here all day then.”

She might not be wrong, in Catra's opinion. Priest should have been busy handling the new Clones and the new Prisoners of War, but the wily Clone was perfectly able to do that and meddle in other things. In fact… She used the remote again. "Let's see if there's anything in the news about him."

"There better not be!"

*****

"...and if we modify the spy bot's search pattern to take the range of the chip's FTL comms into account, we can cover the suspected area under Ba'al's control much faster than anticipated, although at the price of potentially missing forces and bases without any chipped victims."

Jack O'Neill nodded at Carter's report. She - and Entrapta - had come through again. "Will that allow us to find his chip factory and shut it down?" It was best to get confirmation before he made any assumptions that turned out to be wrong.

"If Ba'al is using those chips on staff working there and if that facility is within the area we're searching, yes, sir."

Those were two significant 'ifs'. So, if Ba'al was even more paranoid and kept the chipped slaves from the chip factory, they wouldn't find it like that - unless they stumbled on it. On the other hand, would Ba'al really trust such a key part of his realm to people without mind-control chips? "So, we have to hope he hasn't used a clone of his there - or if he does, he still uses chips."

"If he's chipping his First Prime, I don't think he's shying away from doing it to a clone," Catra said. "The question is: Can he control another Goa'uld with the chips? If they can take over a stunned victim to make the body keep fighting…"

Carter nodded. "While we could not test it, based on the experiments we could run, we believe that the chips could override even a Goa'uld's control of their host."

Jack whistled. “Now, if the other snakes knew about that…”

“You think we should leak that intel to the enemy?” Catra looked at him. “Ba’al’s already fighting a couple of snakes and us; if more get involved, they’ll discover us sooner rather than later.”

She was right, but Jack didn’t think they would be able to hide for much longer. Between the deception with Apophis and now the campaign against Ba’al, when Adora had revealed herself, he had a feeling that the Goa’uld would discover the extent of the Alliance soon anyway. “We shouldn’t underestimate the snakes. They will add two and two together as soon as they can compare information from Apophis and Ba’al.”

“Ba’al has organised his forces in a way that makes it exceedingly difficult for spies to infiltrate his court,” Teal’c said. “And the more mind-control chips he uses, the harder it becomes for a spy to remain effective.”

That was true as well. And frustrating since it also meant the Tok’ra were not nearly as effective as they should be. But… “Yeah, but everything adds up.”

“And you think that we should turn the other Goa’uld against Ba’al before they realise how powerful the Alliance is,” Adora said.

“Yep.” Jack nodded.

“And hope Ba’al doesn’t spill the secret to avoid getting ganged up on,” Catra said.

“That’s a danger,” Jack said. “But can you see Ba’al doing that? He keeps everything compartmentalised.”

“We shouldn’t underestimate him,” Glimmer replied. “We know he is one of the smartest Goa’uld we’ve been fighting.”

“And one of the most cruel,” Adora added. She shook her head. “I think it’s a bit too dangerous to leak the information - it would also show Ba’al how much we know. And I think the Goa’uld

already fighting Ba'al are enough; I don't think we want the other System Lords to move more forces into the theatre - it would make defeating them in detail harder."

Jack slowly nodded. That made sense. And they were right that Ba'al was already one of the System Lords most hated by the rest of the snakes. "So, could those chips protect against being taken over by a snake?" Everyone stared at him, and he shrugged. "Just thinking out loud."

"The chips work by taking control of the central nervous system, sir. I don't think this would result in the victim retaining control of their body, sir," Carter said. "It would just be a puppet for the chip."

And that wouldn't be any better than being a host for a snake. Even if you were fighting for your own side. Jack shuddered.

"Well, unless the chip was programmed to just… reinforce the brain. Kinda," Entrapta said. "But you'd have to have all the brain data for that, and the chip can't really hold that much data. So… not really. But in theory, with much more advanced chips, it could be done - but we'd be copying a brain onto a chip for that, which I think we could if we used the Asgard's transfer technology, but we'd still need better chips."

Everyone was staring at her. Jack included. Had she just proposed a way to copy people's brains into chips and then have the copy take over the original body?

"Uh…" Adora grimaced. "Let's not try to copy people."

Everyone agreed with that.

*****

North of Las Vegas, Nevada, United States of America, Earth, July 19th, 2000

“...and this, Your Divine Highness, is the latest congregation of your faithful!”

Standing next to the shuttle they had taken here, Adora stared. She had seen the pictures, of course - any officer knew how to check the maps before deploying, and while this trip wasn't an actual mission, it sure felt like one - but pictures didn't quite capture the real thing. “It's a giant sword.”

“We considered building it in the shape of a shield, to symbolise Your Divine Protection of those in need, but we felt that emphasising the fight to defeat evil was more appropriate. Also, the building permits were easier to acquire for this design.” Priest beamed.

“You mean, you found a giant cross that was permitted, and so they couldn't deny your sword,” Catra commented.

“The authorities could not deny us what they granted to others already.”

“That explains the giant sword,” Adora said. A tall building in the shape of a sword, point buried in the earth. “But what about the fortress around it?” Those were Horde-style - Hordak's Horde, not Horde Prime's Horde - prefab walls complete with turrets and weapon emplacements - though they looked empty, fortunately.

“We received threats from various extremist elements, and the building permits included fences around the property, Your Divine Highness.”

Adora didn't think anyone would consider walls thick enough to stop a charging hovertank ‘fences’, but she wasn't a building inspector. It wasn't as concerning as the first part of the statement, anyway. “Someone threatened you?” she asked, narrowing her eyes.

“Religious extremists, Your Divine Highness. They take exception to our faith spreading amongst the people of Earth and resort to threats of violence when their propaganda cannot stop Your Word

from reaching those in need." Priest shook his head. "But do not be concerned - their pitiful attempts to scare us will not shake our devotion to Your Divine Truth! As You show us every day by example, we will persevere in the face of any adversity!"

Catra clapped, and Adora glared at her, which only made her lover grin, before she turned to address Priest again: "So, were there any attacks?"

"None so far, no doubt owing to our faithful guards, Your Divine Highness. Although the local fanatics have taken to, ah, 'picket' the building on the days of our celebrations and harass our faithful. Unfortunately, the authorities emphasised that they are allowed to do that by the laws of the land."

"Freedom of speech and blah blah," Catra said, peering through binoculars. "I think I can see them setting up - there's a sign denouncing you as a satanic temptress. And one calling you the whore of Babylon. And a few about 'Hell' awaiting those who follow you."

"We told them that the local satanic temple denied any connection between Your Divine Highness and their own faith, but it did not deter the protesters," Priest added. "Also, unlike Your Divine Name, 'satanic' is not a protected trademark, so the temple could not use legal means to stop this, either."

"My name is a trademark?" Adora hadn't known that.

"We took the steps to prevent people abusing your name and likeness to hurt others, in accordance with your values, Your Divine Highness."

She narrowed her eyes slightly - Priest sounded too smug - and ignored Catra's chuckling. "And to prevent others from selling merchandise, right?"

"Indeed, Your Divine Highness!" Priest nodded. "Your faithful will not be exploited for profit as long as we stand watchful!" He smiled. "Of course, we will limit ourselves to legal means, as Your

Divine Example commands us, and not use the magic You graciously restored to Earth to put curses on those who would attempt to defraud Your faithful.”

That was an oddly specific claim. Adora made a mental note to check with the sorceresses amongst her faithful - those using Earth's magic, at least - to ensure that they were not abusing magic.

“Or your ships to blow up enemies of the faith from orbit,” Catra added.

“Of course not! Orbital bombardment is only allowed on Your Divine Highness's direct order!”

“Oh, look! There's another group protesting!” Catra peered through her binoculars again. “They demand… to ‘Liberate Gaia's Chosen Vessel from Alien Bondage’?”

“It's a very small group of people who labour under the mistaken assumption that Her Divine Highness is actually their native goddess and has been coopted by us like the Goa'uld took over other religious figures,” Priest explained.

“They think I'm a Goa'uld?” Adora clenched her teeth.

“They have not made that claim yet, but given how they seem to grow more radical every time they show up, it might merely be a question of time until they do, Your Divine Highness.”

That… This was slander! “Is that covered by religious freedom?” she asked.

“We are looking forward to the ruling in that case, once we file a suit, Your Divine Highness.” Priest nodded.

“Good.” Adora nodded. “Then let's go visit the congregation.”

Priest bowed deeply at her, and Catra smirked, but Adora ignored both. She hadn't really wanted to visit this church, temple,

whatever, but if such hateful people were gathering outside, spreading such lies, and harassing visitors, then she wouldn't let that stand without making it clear what she thought about them.

*****

Portsmouth Naval Shipyard, Maine, United States of America, Earth, July 20th, 2000

"...and the religious riots that broke out in Nevada following a visit by Princess She-Ra have finally ended according to the state police. While the governor has not yet commented on the incident, stating that the police were still investigating how exactly the riots started, several local politicians have already protested what they consider a 'blatant infringement of religious freedom' and demand the release of anyone arrested during the riot. Meanwhile, sources in Washington D.C. have confirmed that while the US government declined to comment on the incident, there are growing concerns about the involvement of Princess She-Ra in what is considered an internal matter for the American people."

"Thank you, Julie. This incident happening less than two weeks before the first national convention may also influence the election. Amongst growing concerns about America's role in the Alliance, fears of foreign influence are spreading in key demographics. Matthew, you've been talking to people on the ground, so to speak?"

"Yes, Keith. I have been talking to several local residents, and they all agree that the riot was the result of provocative actions taken by the Church of She-Ra."

Samantha Carter frowned at the screen in the corner of the waiting room - sorry, meeting room - in the Navy shipyards, where she was supposed to work on the latest issue that the Constitution II-Class frigate had managed to develop. Why were they interviewing Texans about an incident in Nevada? The two states didn't even share a border!

"...and just ask yourself: What would Jesus do? Why, he would chase them out just as he drove out the money-lenders from the temple!"

"They built a mockery of a church there, to make fun of our faith!"

"I don't have anything against aliens, but they shouldn't force their religion in our face like that."

"It's not a real religion, it's just a scam to get money. Why would they build such a huge building, anyway?"

"Las Vegas is a den of sin."

She didn't see any remote around, so she stood and went over to manually change channels. That particular station didn't deserve to be called news; it was blatant propaganda.

She had to switch channels three more times before she found a news source that was covering the riot in Nevada without engaging in sensationalist rhetoric or speculating whether or not the Church of She-Ra was at fault.

Of course, Sam wouldn't put it past Priest to engineer such an incident, but she didn't think he'd bother; as the news showed, there was considerable support for the attack on the church in the more radical circles of the religious conservatives. Various political and religious leaders might condemn the violence but they also more or less openly blamed the Church of She-Ra for it.

"...and this wouldn't have happened if America were still strong! Our Founding Fathers stood up to the most powerful Empires of their time! They would be ashamed to see how far their country has fallen. These people are lashing out because they don't feel safe anymore. When they look up, they see alien ships in the sky above their heads, not American ones! When they listen to the news about the war against the Goa'uld, they hear about foreign armies and fleets, not American ones! And they wonder where our soldiers and sailors are - and why they can't protect America! This needs to change!"

And that was a leading member of the electoral campaign of the future presidential candidate? Sam shook her head and turned the TV off. It seemed that American politics were taking a turn for the worse. She could only hope that saner heads would prevail.

She turned when she heard the door open behind her and saluted when she saw Admiral Baker enter. “Sir.”

He returned the salute. “At ease, Major Carter. Please excuse the delay; our meeting ran a bit longer than expected; you know how it goes.”

“I am familiar with meetings, sir.” Sam smiled politely and added ‘such as this one’ in her head.

“Good, good. Now, we've called you because we've made a few more changes to the next block of the Constitution II-class, and we need you to figure out how to upgrade the existing ships.” He pushed a button, and a holographic display appeared over the table showing the blueprints of the frigate.

“Yes, sir.” Sam managed not to scowl. More changes?

She looked at the display, quickly going over the highlighted changes. “Expanded magazines?”

“The recent deployments have shown that a frigate needs to be able to operate independently for longer than we have previously anticipated.”

There had been talk about long-range exploration and recon ships, to expand and complement the Spy bot network and conduct exploration, but the Alliance had not yet decided whether it was worth the effort. “The Constitution II-class frigates were designed as ships of the line, sir,” she told him. Badly designed, and arguably useless at that role, but those had been the design parameters. “They're meant to operate in task forces supplied by a fleet train.”

“Yes, but as hybrid ships that offer both carrier and gunship capability, they are perfect for long-range missions where sending an entire task force would not be economical. With just a few changes, we can extend their operational range for that.”

A few changes that would see crew compartments reduced to a point, even submarine crews would consider the ship too cramped. And this was supposed to be a long-range exploration vessel? Not that the extended magazines would actually add enough supplies to handle such missions. And the whole plan ignored that the entire class was still not rated for interstellar deployment outside an emergency!

Sam wanted to scream. This would have never happened if the Air Force had taken the lead for the US space forces!

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, July 21st, 2000

“Well, as you are already aware, the actions of a tiny minority do not reflect the attitude of the vast majority of the American people.”

Catra cocked her head and raised her eyebrows at Daniel's comment, then pointedly looked at the TV in the background showing burning cars in a parking lot in the desert.

He cleared his throat and pushed his glasses up with a finger. “I know how it looks, with every media covering the riots, and how several seem to carefully select the, ah, most sensational statements, but if you look at the actual data, the vast majority of Americans condemn the attack on your church. Religious freedom is one of the basic rights in the country.”

“They claim that we violate their religious freedom,” Adora said.

“Which is obviously false,” Daniel said. “The law is clear about that.”

Catra scoffed. “The law might be clear, but the media aren't.” She knew the difference between how they covered the actions of the Goa'uld and those of those fanatics who had tried to storm the church.

“The media do seem to show a lot more understanding for the motives behind this attack than one would expect if this were a tiny extremist minority,” Priest added.

“It's an election year, and the religious conservatives are an important voting block,” Daniel said. “But all the important churches have condemned the attack as well.”

“They also condemned Her Divine Highness's intervention to save her church,” Priest said. “Even though no one died or was seriously hurt. By any measure, making the ground shake so people fall down is a rather restrained reaction to an attack on the faithful for a divine intervention. Their holy books have much more brutal examples for much less serious offences.”

Catra snorted. “They hate that Adora showed up their own god.”

“I didn't show up anyone!” Adora protested. “I just stopped the attack before they could hurt anyone. Anyone in my position would have done that!”

Catra wasn’t so certain. Sure, the police had arrested all the rioters, but they had been noticeably slow to arrive.

“Indeed, Your Divine Highness.” Priest beamed at Adora. “It is not your fault that the absence of such interventions by other gods might cause some of their faithful to develop doubts about them.”

On the other hand, Catra also had some doubts that Priest was as surprised about the attack as he had claimed. Sure, the protesters had been gathering for days without attacking anyone, but it was pretty convenient that the day they actually attacked was the day Adora was visiting. You'd have to be a complete idiot to try anything with her present. Of course, those people were complete idiots…

“That is an important point, actually,” Daniel said. “While the Church of She-Ra is amongst the smallest religious organisations in the United States, it is growing much faster than any other church. This has been a source of concern for some congregations.”

Catra snorted again. “As I said, they fear the competition.”

“It's not a competition!” Adora objected.

“Indeed, Your Divine Highness!” Priest nodded slowly. “Faith is a personal choice for every individual, not a competition, much less a business. Everyone has to decide for themselves what faith suits them. Anything else would violate their religious freedom. That some religious leaders seem to have a problem with that should raise concerns about them and their faith.”

“Of course,” Daniel agreed. “I'm just pointing out why some religious leaders have concerns.”

“Well, they should take their concerns up with their gods,” Priest replied. “If they were more present in their followers’ lives, I am sure they wouldn't have a reason to be concerned about Her Divine Highness's flock of faithful.”

“I think if their god were present in their lives, they would have a lot more and more serious problems than the competition from Adora,” Catra said with a smirk.

“Well, religious practices and doctrines are a delicate subject,” Daniel said. “Opinions about which rules of a religion should be followed, and how, vary a lot within most faiths.”

Priest shrugged. “That is between the faithful and their gods. If a god decides to remain silent about such disagreements, then they obviously don't care enough about the matter to intervene.”

Adora frowned at him for that. “Or they might not be listening.”

Priest nodded as if he had not noticed the implied criticism. “That is possible, though I think the deities being worshipped on Earth would be able to make themselves heard by their faithful. The stories about them certainly imply such.”

“If they exist in the first place,” Sha're said. “It's hard to believe a real god would have tolerated the Goa’uld usurping their name and faith.”

Priest tilted his head slightly. “That so many people do not doubt their religion despite the lack of a divine presence in their lives is a testament to the power of their faith.”

Despite the honest tone of his statement, Catra was sure that Priest didn't intend it to be a compliment. And she didn't think anyone else thought so.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, July 22nd, 2000

“The Etherians have refused to share the factory ships, General.” The Secretary of Defense was back, and he wasn’t happy. Both about that fact and about Jack O’Neill.

Jack wasn’t happy either. He wasn’t a politician. “I mentioned the ‘optics’, but the Command Council decided that military reasons took priority.”

“You mean the Supreme Commander decided to keep the shipyards for her personal cult, General!”

Jack really shouldn’t have come to Brussels today. Or shouldn’t have decloaked his stealth shuttle. “I think it’s a bit problematic to call an established religion a ‘cult’, sir.”

“It’s a cult!” the Secretary snapped. “Or do you think Princess She-Ra is an actual goddess?”

Jack forced himself to smile widely. “I don’t judge other religions. You never know which might turn out to be the right one.” Alright, that was a bit too snarky, but really - the idiot shouldn’t be blaming Jack for his own failures. He was the politician; Jack was just a soldier.

“This is no joking matter, General! We’re in the middle of an election, and the polls show that this is a key issue for a significant part of the voters!”

“Are you talking about the failed designs being built in our shipyards or the failed religious oppression?” Jack asked. “Just so there’s no misunderstanding.”

“There is no religious oppression in the United States!”

“But ‘key segments of the voters’ seem to think there should be, according to the news,” Jack pointed out.

“There are concerns about new religions aggressively recruiting members, especially amongst teenagers who lack enough life experience to make an informed decision. A valid concern, based on past experiences.”

“I’d be more concerned about religious fanatics trying to burn down churches.” Jack shrugged. “Or our ships being flying coffins.” The Secretary of Defense was responsible for that fiasco; it was his job to ensure that such screwups didn’t happen, especially not in the middle of a war.

“The problems with the Constitution II-class are vastly overblown. None of the ships have suffered a serious accident.”

“None of them have been in a real battle either,” Jack pointed out. “But they haven’t exactly covered themselves with glory in exercises either.”

“Teething problems that will work themselves out. And it ties into the reason I am here, General. I am here because we need those factory ships! Have you seen the latest opinion pieces? They call

us weak! Have you seen the cartoons? They show the United States as a little child hiding behind the skirts of the aliens!"

Jack chuckled. Catra had shown him the cartoon, and Adora had complained that she had never worn such a long skirt.

"It's not funny, General. We can't appear weak. What do you think will happen if we lose the election?"

"We get another government?" Jack shrugged again. That was how democracy worked.

"A government made of people who campaigned on the promise to take a tougher stance against aliens! Do you think that pissing off our allies will help win the war?" The Secretary shook his head. "They'll ruin whatever goodwill we've recovered in the time since First Contact. Do you think the other members of NATO have forgotten that we kept the Stargate a secret from them?"

That hadn't been his fault. Jack hadn't made that decision. "Sir, I've passed on your concerns. But the Etherians - and the other members of the Alliance - don't think that we should hand over the factory ships to the United States. The Europeans also mentioned concerns about crippling their shipbuilding industry by relying on alien factories that would outcompete them."

The Secretary sighed. "I've pointed this out as well, but the public doesn't care about long-term economic policies. They want a fleet of spaceships flying the Star-spangled Banner. The fact that the British ships were seen in action, saving a base, has people asking where our ships are."

"Those transports are altered copies of Horde designs. The British-designed corvettes haven't seen action either so far," Jack pointed out. Though they had performed very well in exercises.

"I know. But the public doesn't care! And the other party is making a big deal about this. We need something to show the American people that we're still a key part of the Alliance - that

we’re not hiding behind anyone! We need a victory from *you*, General.”

Jack had a sinking feeling in his stomach. “I command the Alliance Special Forces - a mixed unit, sir.”

“Yes, but you are the face of our special forces. You and the others from SG-1. Everyone knows that you lead from the front, so we need to use that. It works for princesses, after all.”

That was… Jack wanted to protest that he wasn’t a princess, but that would make him sound like a whiner. And he couldn’t actually argue against leading from the front, could he?

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, July 28th, 2000

“...and I can only say it again: America deserves better! We have fought the Goa'uld alone for years! Stargate Command killed Ra, the Goa'uld's supreme leader, without any help from anyone! We struggled and fought and saved the entire Earth! And yet, the current administration has squandered all that. Instead of leading the Alliance with our experience, Stargate Command has been put under the command of the United Nations and turned into a travel agency! Our best soldiers are doing gatekeeper duty! What has gone wrong here?”

“That's a very biased take on our past, Jim. Stargate Command has fought the Goa'uld and eliminated Ra, but there was a lot of luck involved. You can't compare those missions with the war we're waging now. Stargate Command never had any spaceships, much less fleets of them. And I believe that most Americans would agree that fighting aliens without telling anyone, not even our closest allies, was a mistake.”

“A mistake the current administration has made, Heith! Another reason why it should be replaced!”

"A mistake from which the current administration has learned. Unlike your party, which seems determined to repeat the same mistake of making unilateral decisions about the war - and ignoring the reality of the situation."

"We're not talking about taking over the Alliance…"

"Yes, you are. Your candidate spoke at length about the need for 'American leadership' in this war!"

"...we are talking about not letting two dozen foreign countries and aliens decide American policies."

"You have been very vague about which policies you want to change, Jim. Would you care to be more specific? Which policies do you feel were forced on the American people? And how was that done? Did someone bypass Congress?"

"That's sophistry! You are well aware that we didn't have any choice but to change our laws - and the constitution! - with a fleet of spaceships flying above our heads! Do you think gunboat diplomacy is acceptable?"

"Are you insinuating that the Alliance fleet would have attacked the United States if we had chosen not to join the Alliance?"

"They certainly intervened in Iran, didn't they?"

"They intervened to stop crimes against humanity - something the United States has done as well, with your support, as I recall."

"You cannot compare the United States to Iran!"

"I didn't have to - you did it! And do I really have to remind you that the Etherians did not force any country to change their policies even when they disagreed with them? The changes to our laws and the amendment to the constitution were the decisions of the American people and their representatives on the federal and state levels. As it should be."

"What would have been the alternative? To be relegated to a third-world country stuck on Earth while everyone else built spaceships to colonise the stars? That was no choice at all! America deserves better!"

Adora shut off the TV. "That's going to be their motto, right? 'America deserves better'?"

"It seems so. It's a catchy slogan," Daniel said. "And it's hard to disagree with the idea that America should improve. It's just that people differ on how exactly America should improve."

That was a bit of an understatement, in Adora's opinion. She wasn't an expert on Earth politics, but some things were very hard to miss. "It seems to me that at least one party feels that in order to improve America, they need to beat others."

"And they don't mean the Goa'uld," Glimmer added. "They mean the rest of the Alliance. And all those complaints about being forced to change their policies? They want to be able to discriminate against people like us again!"

"I don't believe anyone seriously expects to be able to turn back the clock. Changing the constitution is very difficult - by design - and the latest amendment has far too much support from key states to be repelled again," Daniel pointed out.

"But they're playing up the fact that this was a condition to join the Alliance to create and build up fear that the Alliance will force more changes on the United States," Glimmer retorted. "And they are targeting the same people who opposed the changes in the first place because they want their support. That's not a good sign."

"Not at all," Adora agreed. What could you expect from a government that came into power through such means? Nothing good.

"And they can do a lot without changing the constitution," Catra added. "Just picking what laws they enforce will cause changes."

It was the same in the Horde - if you didn't crack down on corruption, every quartermaster stole as much as possible from their magazines.

“I think that's a bit too harsh. A new government is still bound by the constitution and the treaties we've made,” Daniel said. “The President isn't a monarch. They do not have absolute power - there are checks and balances for a reason.” He smiled. “The current administration might be playing up the amount of changes that could be enacted in order to gain concessions from the Alliance.”

Adora sighed. “I've noticed that. Now that they couldn't get the factory ships we captured, they want some great victory so they can show the American public that they're strong.”

“Well…” Daniel shrugged. “A great victory over the Goa'uld wouldn't be a bad thing, would it?”

He was right, of course, but…

“If you need a victory to keep your position and power, you tend to take risks and gambles that you normally wouldn't,” Catra voiced Adora's thoughts. “And that tends to end badly.”

Adora nodded. “We won't rush into a battle just to save the American government.” They wouldn't sacrifice soldiers for political gains. Not on her watch.

Glimmer nodded. “If they don't want to be voted out they shouldn't have made their country a democracy.”

Daniel frowned at her. “On Earth, the less democratic nations are generally far more conservative. All the members of the Alliance are democracies.”

“Well, Earth is weird,” Glimmer shot back, flushing a little. “That wouldn't happen if you had proper princesses.”

Bow cleared his throat. “Etheria has numerous examples of similarly unfit leaders, both in the past and in the present.”

That earned him a frown from Glimmer, but he wasn't wrong, in Adora's opinion. Politics were far too often far too frustrating. War was worse, of course, but at least you could hit your enemy on the battlefield. And…

Her tablet beeped. Priority message? She checked it. And then she smiled. “It's from Entrapta and Sam. The bots have found a mind-control network!”

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The Election Campaign Part 1

Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, July 31st, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We should have worked on improving the stealth generator design so it can hide a frigate," Samantha Carter said as she stared at the screen displaying the data from the spy bot network in the area. It could barely be called a network, actually - it was more like a thin cloud of bots spread out to cover as much space as possible and check for mind-control chip signals.

Although she had already changed the deployment order for the spy bots to create a real network - if they wanted to operate in the area, they would need as close a coverage of the space as possible. Unfortunately, with the way the bots were spreading out, even with priorities altered, it would take some time for the next wave of spy bots to fill in the gaps - the spy bots could only move so fast and so far in the time allotted, and too many were already set to push the general search pattern forward.

"Why?" Entrapta asked from Sam's side. "I mean, it would have a huge advantage in combat, although the Goa'uld will realise how good our stealth technology is if we start fielding it openly in battles, but it would require a lot of effort to manage that, and the costs involved would mean we couldn't really build that many frigates."

"It would be safer for recon missions than a stealth shuttle," Sam said.

"If we can scale up the generator to cover a frigate, we would likely also be able to improve the field, so a shuttle would still be better hidden," Entrapta pointed out.

"That's likely but not certain," Sam said. "But we have a better chance to escape an enemy if we use a frigate since the shields would be much stronger, and it would also be faster."

“But we would be easier to detect and to hit.” Entrapta shrugged. “But we can work on it and see if we can find a solution to the threshold problem.”

“Yes.” Although that would likely require an entirely new approach - the current technology’s drain on power grew exponentially the more space it needed to cover and the more emissions it had to hide. They could likely cover a frigate, but it would end up having to fly at a snail’s pace and have almost no power left for propulsion, shields and weapons - although the weapons could be compensated for by using missiles, those didn’t require a lot of power to launch. It would have to operate like a submarine, though, relying on ambushes and then stealth to get away - and that would likely be easier to achieve by using stealth shuttles to deliver missiles or bombs, operating from a carrier…

She snorted softly at herself getting lost on a tangent. Her good humour vanished, though, when she realised that the US Navy would likely jump on either design and treat them as space versions of submarines and carriers. And they had already proven that they couldn’t be trusted with adapting warships to space.

“Alright! I’ve filtered more data in our analysis!” Entrapta’s cheerful voice interrupted Sam’s thoughts. “We should now be able to pinpoint the sources of the chip signals.”

That would be a breakthrough - and the reason they were out here, in a stealth shuttle, a bit too far from the Alliance task force covering the area for Sam’s taste. “Let me check,” Sam said, already switching the feeds on her screen.

Yes, the signals had been filtered - and with the adjusted and increased coverage of the area, at the expense of other parts of this sector, they now had identified multiple individual chips. “They’re using the same base codes,” Sam said.

“Yes! But they also use a floating control node,” Entrapta said. “So, we can’t hack it before we isolate that node.”

And that would alert the Goa'uld forces that someone was attacking them. "We can scout the area and gather information without hacking the network," Sam said. "But we'll need more spy bots for that before we send in stealth shuttles." They needed to know how extensive - and how powerful - the enemy sensor coverage was before risking people.

"Yes!" Entrapta nodded. "We can close the gaps and check the entire area around the signals."

Unlike Point Velvet, this site was set in a star system. That lowered the chances that this was the chip production site they were seeking since systems tended to draw more attention and visitors than empty spots in deep space. On the other hand, trying to second-guess the enemy without sufficient information was a fool's errand, so Sam didn't say that out loud.

Instead, she sifted through the growing amounts of data that they received from the spy bots. They couldn't hack the chips, and the ever-changing patterns from the floating control node also made breaking the encryption even harder than it already was, but they could analyse the traffic - and soon, they would be able to compare it to regular data from other sources in the area.

Whatever Ba'al's forces were up to here, the Alliance would soon know.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, July 31st, 2000

"...and we have gathered here not just to choose the next President of the United States, but to choose the path for America and the world! The current administration has shown what future they want for our beloved country: A future where we will be beholden, dependent on others - other countries, aliens. Following their rules, their customs, even their gods! A future where America is weak! Too weak to protect itself. Too weak to stand for

ourselves. Too weak to chart our own course. Is this the future you want?"

Catra rolled her eyes, her ears twitching at the TV's speaker as the assembled crowd visible on the screen loudly yelled: *"No!"*

"No, we don't want that future! America deserves better! We want a future where America is strong! Strong enough not to need anyone's help! Strong enough to protect our people and our culture! Strong enough to lead the rest of the world as we did before - to once again be the shining city on the hill everyone else aspires to!"

"America deserves better!"

"They say the world changed, and we need to adapt! We say: We need to take a stand and tell the world that we won't bend! America deserves better!"

"America deserves better!"

"Turn it off, Catra! We have an important meeting!" Glimmer complained.

Catra scoffed. "It's not starting yet."

"I don't want to see this."

"Tough. We need to keep an eye on this." If the people gathered at this 'National Convention' managed to win the next election, things would get difficult in the Alliance. The United States weren't the most agreeable member of the alliance to begin with, but at least the current president realised that they couldn't just act as if they were the most powerful member of the Alliance. Those people on the screen yelling about deserving better? Catra wasn't sure she had been more out of touch with reality in her worst moment in the Horde.

"Why? Mr Brown and Julie have already explained that we can't really do anything without starting complaints about election

interference and making things worse since that would push more people to support those idiots." Glimmer frowned.

"It's still better to know what's coming instead of remaining ignorant," Catra said. "We need to be ready to adapt."

"We are. If the Americans choose to be stupid, we'll rely on the rest of NATO." Glimmer shrugged again. "It'll make things a bit more difficult, but they have more ground forces than the United States, and Earth still hasn't much of a fleet."

Catra knew that. Though she also knew that that would change. "Worst case, the Americans leave the Alliance and build up their forces while we fight the war."

"They won't do that," Glimmer said. She nodded at the screen. "Those people are too hyped up about fighting the Goa'uld. They probably charge straight at the next System Lord with their deathtraps."

"Yeah," Catra agreed. "That's why I said worst case. If they were smart, they'd let us bleed while they build up their forces, and then take over when we're all weak. They already did that after their last World War." Which was probably why some of the other Alliance members from Earth seemed to hope the Americans would change governments. Earth people kept their grudges forever. If the Horde had tried to conquer Earth, Catra would be in prison for life - if she was lucky.

And maybe I would deserve it.

She pushed the thought away. "So, Adora's still stuck in the procurement meeting." Which was also known as the pork piggy bank session, according to Jack, but she knew better than to trust him even though the few times she had taken part in it, it had been exactly that.

"Yes." Glimmer frowned, staring at her tablet. "Entrapta and Sam are still gathering data from the spy bots."

Catra knew that. They didn't have the intel they needed to plan the next operation yet. "And we're going to discuss how to bring journalists along on a mission without getting them killed or leaking classified information so the United States government can show their voters that they are an important member of the Alliance."

"Things would be so much easier if they had a proper princess," Glimmer muttered.

Catra wasn't quite sure - an American princess would probably be as difficult to work with as Princess Sweet Bee. At least if you looked at their news.

"...and we should… what's that?"

"Oh my God!"

"Security!"

Catra whipped her head around and stared at the screen. The speaker had collapsed on the podium and was… vomiting blood? Yes, blood was coming out of his mouth, nose, ears and eyes. And he was thrashing around as if he were being tased. But there was no attacker visible.

Magic. Had to be magic. Probably one of those Earth magic curses.

Shit.

*****

Alliance Base Lübtheen, Mecklenburg-Vorpommern, Germany, August 1st, 2000

"...and while the investigation has just started - the FBI's specialists have taken over only hours before - the party's leadership has already released a statement blaming 'witches' and 'eco terrorists' for the magical attack on Mr James Delan in the

middle of his speech at the first day of the National Convention, and…"

"...Mr Delan remains in critical condition at the Thomas Jefferson University Hospital. His family refused magical healing from Princess She-Ra on the grounds of not wishing to endanger his immortal soul and asked people to pray for him, but…"

Jack O'Neill scoffed. "Fat load of good prayers will do for him." If that worked, Jack would have a few more friends left. "Wanna bet that his family's already dividing up his estate?" he asked, turning to the two people in his office.

"No bet," Special Agent Wilkinson (on detached duty) said. "In any murder, you look first to the relatives of the victim."

"It's not yet a murder, Wilkinson," Special Agent Paris said. She shook her head. "We can't tell yet if he will succumb to whatever curse has been placed on him or not."

"Are we even sure that it is a curse?" Jack said.

Paris nodded. "I've checked with a colleague - they've identified magic influence. The current theory is sympathetic magic."

"Doesn't look very sympathetic to me," Wilkinson commented.

"It means magic cast on the target using a sympathetic link," Paris explained. After a moment, she added: "Voodoo."

Ah! Jack nodded. "So, did they already check his hairdresser?" he joked.

"Matter of fact, yes," Paris, serious as ever, replied.

"Well, will the FBI ask for you back?" Jack asked. "Looks like they'll need all the sorceresses they can get for this case."

"Thaumaturgists, General." Paris pressed her lips together for a moment. "I was told I shouldn't expect such a request. Officially

since I am needed in the war. Unofficially, the bureau doesn't want to deal with accusations of biased investigators."

Wilkinson snorted. "Good luck with that. Did you hear the statements? I'll bet they'll call to replace all Thaumaturgists with witch hunters next."

Jack chuckled even though he was pretty sure that this would actually happen.

Paris, though, looked even more pissed-off. "You cannot solve such a case without magic."

"Maybe they'll find a priest who has a talent for magic but thinks it comes from God?" Wilkinson shrugged. "Could be a profitable niche. Exorcist, witch hunter… I bet a lot of states would hire them."

And Jack lost all humor at that thought. The absolute last thing America needed was another Salem. "Let's hope it doesn't come to that. We really don't need an intervention by the Alliance on US soil."

That seemed to shock both (nominal) special agents. "Would the Alliance really intervene in the US?" Wilkinson asked. "Of course, they would," he answered his own question a moment later. "Shit."

"Yeah." Jack nodded. "That's one of the lines the Etherians won't let anyone cross." It was one thing for a mob to gather in a country in the Middle East and murder a few poor victims, it was another for a state to not only condone that but officially engage in such witch hunts. Even the Saudis had stopped that stuff by now - no one wanted another intervention like in Iran.

"If the number of criminal magic users grows, and I believe it will, more police forces with magical talents will be needed," Paris said. "I don't think the Alliance will oppose that. None of the Etherian mages have ever had a problem with me."

“It's the witch hunter part,” Jack explained. “That has certain implications that trigger our friends. Especially after those fanatics tried to burn down that church of She-Ra in Nevada.”

“They'll think we're no better than Iran. Shit,” Wilkinson cursed again.

Jack looked at the TV again.

“...and this wouldn't have happened if we hadn't lost our way. America deserves better! It's one Nation under God - or it should be! Not one nation under alien heathens and their witch friends! It's only by the grace of God my dear friend and colleague is still alive, and it's with God's help that we will save our nation's soul!”

“Well, it is kinda hard to see the difference right now,” Jack said.

“If they don't put a lid on that, we'll have witch hunts in America,” Wilkinson said.

“We already had several murders where the culprits thought the victim was a witch,” Paris pointed out.

“Murders, yes. But if things get worse, we'll see lynchings,” Wilkinson said.

And if they went after followers of the Church of She-Ra… Jack winced. Priest might hold back from intervening, the Clone seemed to prefer a soft approach, but if the police in certain states followed their old playbooks and politicians encouraged them to look away if a mob gathered, that would change.

He looked at the TV again.

“...and following this heinous attack on a good, god-fearing man, father and husband, it's clear that we need to regulate and control magic. We cannot let terrorists and witches attack innocent people with curses - the government needs to stop this! Once we retake our nation's helm, we will implement strict measures to ensure

that magic will be brought under control and our people will be safe! Magic is too dangerous to let just anyone practice it!"

"I wonder if he'd say the same about gun control," Paris said.

Jack tensed at the familiar pain and guilt that brought up. If he hadn't kept a loaded gun at home… He forced the thought away. He had a lot of problems to focus on and couldn't dwell on that. Not if he wanted to prevent more tragedies.

Even though he doubted he could do much about that.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, August 2nd, 2000

Adora knew she couldn't go to the national convention. She was needed here in the Alliance Headquarters to prepare the next operation - as soon as Entrapta and Sam finished their recon of whatever Ba'al was hiding in that system and they had enough intel to properly plan the mission. They were already moving a task force into position, but without definite intel, they had to prepare for the reinforcements as well, and even with fleet trains, supply lines had to be prepared, just in case they had to occupy the system on a permanent basis. Ground forces, especially Earth forces, also had a much larger logistical footprint than Clones who were primarily spaceship crew and used bots for far more roles.

And she also knew that if she went to Philadelphia, it wouldn't help anyone. The family of the victim had refused her help already, and all the speakers were blaming the attack on her for releasing Earth's magic in the first place. Some even went further and implied that she had ordered the attack. With the number of worked-up people attending the convention, she'd cause another riot if she went there.

But she wanted to go anyway. Being unable to do anything while everything went wrong was torture! She could heal a dying man,

show that magic wasn't the problem, show those people that she wasn't their enemy, if they would only let them!

But they wouldn't. As Glimmer had said, they were ‘milking this’ for all that it was worth. If she turned the TV on, she would see snippet after snippet of people blaming magic, Etheria and herself for everything that went wrong in their lives. And, as Catra had said, probably for stuff that they only imagined going wrong.

She shook her head and focused on the holoprojection in front of her. The latest troop movements on the Goa'uld front - well, the intel from the realms of Apophis, Sokar and Heru'ur, in this case. They were still in a three-way conflict, but it had slowed down compared to last year. Apophis was trying to consolidate and rebuild his forces and was mostly sticking to counter-attacks - according to the Tok'ra, he was concerned with showing weakness or he'd limit his operations even more. Heru'ur had been distracted from attacking Apophis on a broad front by Sokar's flanking attack and had moved the bulk of his forces to face them. And Sokar was both maintaining a credible defence against Apophis to deter serious attacks and trying to overwhelm Heru'ur’s forces with numerical superiority, but - so the intel claimed - was finding out that terrorising your own troops into loyalty unto death wasn't as effective as inspiring your forces by fighting at their side on the frontlines and sharing the danger. Heru'ur’s Jaffa genuinely loved their master, and even the Tok'ra agreed that the sentiment was returned by the System Lord. They were holding back Sokar's forces but were not yet able to go on the offensive.

Still, as stable as it seemed for now, sooner or later, Apophis would try to take back what he had lost to the Alliance, and then things would get even more complicated. They had to defeat Ba'al as soon as possible, not just to end the threat his advanced technology and machinations posed, but also to free up more troops.

And for that, they needed more intel. She changed the projection to show the suspected space of Ba'al's realm, with the spreading

spy bot network overlaid. Their coverage was growing, but it wasn't as dense as it should be for dependable surveillance. The holes in coverage were just too great, and the increased focus on the latest target area meant the holes would stay - even the rate at which the spy bots were spreading had gone down with more diverted to the system Entrapta and Sam were investigating. They needed that - if they wanted to operate a task force there, they had to have the best advance warning possible in case there were reinforcements coming - but Adora didn't like it anyway. Those gaps in the network worried her. Ba'al was a cunning enemy, and he had surprised the Alliance too often already.

"Brooding over the spy bot network?" Catra asked from where she was going over logistics reports. Adora frowned at her - she wasn't brooding! - and her love snorted. "Ba'al isn't aware of our bots. He'd need a lot of luck to send a fleet through the gaps of our network without being detected."

"We think he doesn't know about our network," Adora corrected her.

"Even if he were aware of them, he'd still need a way to detect them."

"He could be hacking them - and taking over our own network to use against us."

Catra shrugged. "He'd have to beat Entrapta and Sam for that. I know on whom I'd bet. If Ba'al were a better hacker, his chips and his command networks would be much better."

That was correct - and Adora had told herself that before - but she couldn't help worrying. It was her duty to worry about things like that, after all, as Supreme Commander of the Alliance. She was supposed to think of potential threats before they manifested. Or, at least, have people anticipate and prepare for such threats.

She glanced at the holoprojection again. If they placed recon units in the worst gaps, they would have additional coverage - and have

units ready to reinforce the task force for the next operation, if they were needed. Or to penetrate deeper into Ba'al's realm. That would reduce the operational reserve in the theatre, but… Adora nodded. The reserve wouldn't be as useful as it should be if they were too late to react because they missed an attack.

She started writing the orders.

*****

Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 2nd, 2000 (Earth Time)

The data analysis was done, and Samantha Carter was looking at the results. "This isn't an isolated system containing his chip factory. This system has more forces than Point Velvet had."

Even adjusting for the discrepancy in power between a Ha'tak and a Horde frigate, the system had double the protection of the other site. The relative power was even greater if those Ha'taks had been upgraded with Horde technology - and Sam was sure they had been; she merely didn't know how many ships and, more importantly, by how much. The upgraded Ha'taks they had encountered so far had been outfitted with beam cannons but otherwise been kept to Goa'uld standards. If those ships had Horde-level shield generators and engines, they would be the equal of a Horde frigate - not quite as fast and agile, but better protected. Alliance tactics would have to be adjusted to fight them.

"Yes! And they patrol the outskirts much more heavily than expected, too!" Entrapta agreed. "The number of Death Gliders is huge - if those are all stationed on Ha'taks, that would mean our preliminary estimate has to be adjusted again. But I don't think they would operate so many fighters without a matching increase in communication traffic."

That would mean the majority of the Death Gliders were stationed on one of the worlds - or one of their moons. "That would have to be the main world, then," Sam said. "None of the other worlds

have enough communication traffic to handle so many Death Gliders."

"And it's the only world where you don't need protective gear to operate outside sealed environments," Entrapta added.

"On the other hand, those ships here show significantly increased communication traffic compared to the other ships." Sam pointed at the data detailing the intercepted traffic.

"Those are too numerous for communication hubs," Entrapta said. "They don't need that many for that number of ships. Did Ba'al change his policy of keeping his forces divided and has switched to centralised detailed controls?"

That was a possibility, but Sam didn't think so - none of the intel from other areas within Ba'al's suspected realm showed a matching increase in communications. And the communication traffic seemed more… contained might not be the correct term. It was… What was that? She quickly ran a few comparisons and a detailed, if limited analysis. Yes. "I think they are coordinating the Death Gliders," she said. "There are pattern shifts that line up with communication traffic."

"Oh, yes!" Entrapta nodded, her hair weaving and bopping. "That does match. So, are those ships carriers? Ha'taks can't carry as many Death Gliders as the signals indicate they control. Or did they subordinate the fighters to those ships?"

That seemed contrary to the general dogma of Ba'al's forces, which was based on compartmentalisation. "Until we can identify the different ships, we can't tell." The spy bots were keeping their distance so far; they didn't know how good the sensors were in those ships. And the Alliance wanted to wait until they had a task force able to take on their worst estimates before finding out, to give the enemy no warning before an attack.

Sam didn't fully agree with that plan; they would have to rely on estimates based on potentially insufficient data to judge the

necessary size of the task force. If they were too wrong, they would have to abort the entire operation and leave Ba'al aware that they had discovered what Sam was increasingly confident was the heart of his realm.

But the orders were clear, and Sam didn't think even the General would exceed or ignore them at this point, were he in her place. They didn't have enough data and intel for such a decision. They hadn't observed the system long enough for solid deductions in key areas, either. They were reasonably certain that the system contained repair facilities based on the signals from ships that appeared for the first time without matching hyperspace windows, but they couldn’t determine if those were repaired ships or freshly built - and they hadn't been able to observe the system long enough to tell any production rates for the latter.

“Hm. That is odd.”

“What is odd?” Sam looked at her friend.

“Check the differences in their patrol patterns on the micro-level,” Entrapta said.

Sam frowned and did so. Her friend was correct - she could see a noticeable difference in the performance curves of the Death Gliders. The vast majority of the fighters all performed very similarly in all parameters - holding formation, matching speed, course changes - while about a tenth of them diverged more or less significantly, although all were within the margins expected of competent Jaffa pilots.

Her eyes widened. No, the vast majority of the Death Gliders were performing manoeuvres with almost perfect precision. Quite superior to the average Jaffa pilot based on past observations. Either Ba'al had an elite training academy for pilots here - no, even such academies wouldn't produce such a homogenous corps of pilots. “There are only two possible explanations for this,” she said.

“Bots or mind-copied clones.” Entrapta nodded.

Sam wasn’t sure what would be worse for the Alliance.

*****

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, August 3rd, 2000

“...and while the police have yet to release a statement, anonymous sources claim that there has been an arrest in the investigation of the magical attack on James Delan at the national convention in Philadelphia that has shocked the nation. People have gathered outside the Thomas Jefferson University Hospital to show their support for the politician who is still in critical condition, with Minister Smith from Mr Delan's church leading them in prayer. Meanwhile, the demands for strict regulation of magic are growing despite several voices decrying this as hasty. Mr Delan's family hasn't declined to comment on the issue.”

Catra frowned, muted the TV and turned to Jack. “Do we know who they arrested?”

“I'm Air Force, not police,” he replied.

Catra raised her eyebrows.

He snorted. “The FBI is playing this very close to their chest. Neither Wilkinson nor Paris have found out anything.”

“Ah. Too bad.” Catra shook her head. The whole affair was extremely annoying. Delan wasn't the first victim of Earth magic, not by far, but he was the first to have been attacked on live TV in the USA - and the first American politician to be attacked like this. Of course, that would spook all his colleagues. “We'll have to consider the effect on our recruitment of sorceresses,” she said.

“If they crack down on magic, many American sorceresses might join the Alliance - or ask for asylum in Etheria,” Glimmer said. “We

already had several such requests from other countries where sorceresses are persecuted."

"Americans fleeing to other countries?" Jack muttered a curse under his breath. "It feels like Vietnam all over again."

"Well, many Americans, especially in subcultures or members of minorities, know what 'strictly regulating magic' means," Daniel said. "Especially if it's coming from the same people who opposed the civil rights movement. You can't blame them for not wanting to end up burned at the stake by a lynch mob or 'shot while resisting arrest'."

"Joy. We might lose the 101st from our forces because they need to revisit Arkansas," Jack muttered.

"What do you mean?" Glimmer asked.

"In 1957, the 101st division was ordered to move to Little Rock in Arkansas to protect the first nine students of colour attending the formerly all-white high school there," Daniel explained.

"You had to use the army to protect *students*?" Adora sounded shocked.

"It was almost fifty years ago," Jack replied. "But yes."

"Living memory, Jack," Daniel said. "And history might repeat itself."

"Unless, of course, those bigots win the election," Catra commented.

"We should release a statement," Adora said.

"That would be seen as foreign interference," Daniel said. "It might have the opposite effect and push more people to support such policies out of spite."

“Idiots,” Catra muttered - but she could understand that kind of thinking. She'd been such an idiot herself, if not a bigot.

“Then we should step up the PR efforts of the Alliance,” Glimmer said. “Emphasise that magic is not evil but can help a lot of people.”

“I could heal people,” Adora said.

Catra rolled her eyes. “Then they will expect you to do that all the time and grow angry if you don't spend all your time healing people. We already settled that.” She glared at her lover - she wouldn't let Adora do that to herself.

“Yes. Besides, we should show what good things Earth sorceresses do,” Glimmer said. “This is about Earth’s magical traditions, not Etheria's.”

“I don't think the zealots blaming magic are making that distinction,” Jack snorted. “Some are blaming Dungeons and Dragons for this.”

“Seriously?” Catra leaned forward. That was the miniature game Bow had mentioned before. “They think that game can teach you magic?”

Daniel nodded. “Yes.”

Catra shook her head. “Anyway, so you want to send our few Earth sorceresses on a PR tour?”

“No.” Glimmer shook her head. “But since we are about to let journalists tag along with our soldiers thanks to the demands from the American government, we can let them see Earth sorceresses fight the Goa'uld.”

Catra wasn't sure if seeing sorceresses using magic against their enemies would help a lot. But it was probably better than nothing.

“And we need to ensure that our sorceresses don't get poached,” Jack said.

“Poached?” Adora asked.

“A lot of rich and powerful people just saw one of their own get cursed on TV. They'll want to hire sorceresses as bodyguards,” Jack said.

Right. Catra could see that. “And some of them will be the same people who want to crack down on magic, I guess.”

“Exactly,” Jack said with a wry grin.

“Hypocrites.” Catra was about to add something else when she caught the banner scrolling over the TV screen at the wall. Breaking news? She unmuted the TV.

“...and according to the FBI, the suspect, a family member of the victim, has confessed to cursing Mr Delan with magic but claims that she was sexually abused by him since her childhood. The FBI has stated that they are investigating the accusations based on material found in Mr Delan's home. His family has refused to comment.”

“Shit.”

Catra nodded. That was… well, if it was true it would change things.

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Child abuse? Jack O'Neill clenched his teeth. That put a different spin on things.

“Isn't it unusual for the FBI to release such information at such an early stage of the investigation?” Daniel asked.

“Either they release it or it gets leaked,” Jack said. “That way, they might have a bit more control over what is released.” Might. The

way the media was focusing on this story, the way it was plastered all over the country - and the world - there would be countless reporters and journalists trying to dig up anything even tangentially related to the case. And, of course, spooks, both foreign and domestic.

Hell! Jack tensed at the thought - what if that was NID's doing? Kinsey and his pals would not blink at manufacturing and planting evidence of child abuse to deal with a 'problem'; he was pretty sure not all of the conservative politicians and church leaders who had been exposed and arrested in the lead-up to the constitutional amendment had been as guilty of the various crimes as the evidence found might have proven.

On the other hand, thanks to his past, Jack knew better than most that a cover-up on that scale, faced with a priority investigation by the FBI and the eyes of the entire country on them, needed more preparation time than a few days to hold up under that kind of scrutiny. And the FBI wouldn't risk revealing such information if they weren't dead sure that the evidence was legit - they knew how the game was played as well.

No, the whole thing was probably legit. Damn. What a mess.

"Well, that should discredit the whole thing," Glimmer said. "It's now self-defence." She sounded a bit too smug for Jack's taste.

"I doubt that cursing someone from afar would actually qualify as self-defence," Daniel said. "You would need an imminent threat to life and limb for that. It would have been expected of you to call the police instead."

Jack had mixed feelings about that. Delan came from a rural district. The local police were quite a bit 'understanding' when it came to bigwigs like him in such areas. Especially if it involved accusations of rape. And from Delan's own family? "That might not have worked out too well, Daniel," he said.

“I am aware of that, Jack.” Daniel grimaced. “And I don’t approve, of course, of the attitude. But my point about this not counting as self-defence still stands. I'm afraid, but while this will put off some of the people who were calling for strict regulation of magic, more will still press on.”

Some of them might be even more motivated now, Jack thought, because they’re afraid their own victims might use magic to strike back.

“That's stupid!” Glimmer blurted out.

“I don't disagree about that either,” Daniel said with a rueful smile. “But a significant part of the American people oppose magic on religious grounds. They will support any attempt to control magic.”

Catra scoffed. “And a huge part of them also hate people like us.”

Jack wasn’t about to disagree with her - he had seen the clips from the convention himself. Sure, the politicians were too smart to say it out loud and limited themselves to veiled references about concerns, especially for children - and wasn't that painfully ironic right now? - but their base had less self-control.

“Well, yes.” Daniel nodded. “They were used to being the most powerful country on Earth. Losing that position shook them up.”

“Those people oppose change,” Sha're said with a scowl. “Especially if it means granting others more rights or power. In that, they are very much like the Goa'uld.”

Daniel would call that an ‘inflammatory statement’. Jack would call it fighting words. But they were true nonetheless. He had met enough of his so-called peers in the officer corps to know that. It was one of the reasons Stargate Command had had to screen their recruits so thoroughly; you really didn’t want such people to step through a gate and meet alien cultures. Earth had enough enemies already.

“Well, at least this will be a setback for the opposition party.” Adora smiled, though it looked a bit forced. “That should take some pressure off the American government.”

“Hopefully, they will stop their demands as well,” Glimmer muttered.

Jack shook his head. “I doubt that. They don't want to sling mud at the opposing party. That never ends well. They want good news that they can tout as their work.”

“They have factories producing advanced technology opening up at a steady pace,” Daniel said. “Some analysts have said that this might reverse the trend to de-industrialise America. And the war is going well.”

That was true - though Jack was a bit sceptical about the latter; money talked as always - but it wouldn't be enough. More factories were old news. And the people needed more and bigger victories. “Well, let's work on delivering the next victory, then,” he said. “Carter and Entrapta’s latest intel looks quite promising.” And also dangerous. He didn't like the thought of having them venture so close to so many enemy forces. Especially with him on Earth, unable to do anything should something go wrong.

“Yes, we should…” Adora started to say.

“Shh! Look at that!” Catra interrupted her, pointing at the screen and reaching for the remote.

“...and in a sudden, almost stunning twist, Minister Smith, the leader of the church Mr Delan and his family attend, has been arrested as well. While the police have not released any information about the charges levelled against him, rumours claim that he was involved in the sexual abuse allegedly committed by Mr Delan. Stay tuned for more information as the situation unfolds!”

Well, Jack couldn't claim he was surprised by this.

I can’t wait to get back to the front.

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The Election Campaign Part 2

Alliance Headquarters, Brussels, Belgium, August 3rd, 2000

"Alright. This is what we know about the target system."

Adora pushed a button, and the holoprojector built into the table lit up, showing a star system with several planets and all the spaceships the spy bots had observed so far.

"That's a massive fleet," Jack commented with a whistle. "Even if you discount the Death Gliders, we'll need more ships to take them on. Especially if they're upgraded Ha'taks."

Adora nodded. "Worst estimate is that all the Ha'taks have been upgraded with Horde weapons, shields and engines. That would mean they are on par or even a bit more powerful than our own upgraded Horde frigates. They would be slower because they are much larger, but they would be tougher even if we take the improved beam cannons we use into account." And while you could leverage better speed and manoeuvrability into winning against a slower but tougher foe, all other things equal, you couldn't do so without taking a considerable risk - at least, unless you were so much faster and more agile, they couldn't hit you at all without blind luck - and you were likely getting hurt in the process. That went for close quarters combat as well as for space battles.

"Then we need numerical superiority," Admiral Brown-Emerson said. "Otherwise, the risk of taking unsustainable losses is too great - especially if we have to deal with Death Gliders making suicide attacks. That number would quickly overwhelm our defences."

Adora nodded and was about to agree when Admiral Biggs scoffed: "When the Japanese tried their Kamikaze bombers, we dealt with them easily enough. We've beaten Ba'al's fleets

whenever we faced them. This will be a little tougher, but we'll take them."

"That's easy to say since if it won't be your ships doing the fighting, Admiral," Jack said with a scowl.

"That should be '*our* ships', General. Or do you not consider yourself a member of the United States Armed Forces any more?" Biggs retorted with a sneer before turning to look at Adora. "Even if we take the worst estimates of the enemy forces' power, all projections agree that the ships assembled for this operation are sufficient to take the objective."

"As Admiral Brown-Emerson said, with our current task force, we'll risk taking heavy losses," Glimmer interjected.

"We can replace those losses. This must be Ba'al's core system and the heart of his Empire. Take it out, and he's done for. Then we can rebuild. But the longer we wait, the tougher this will be - he's building ships as we speak," Biggs countered.

"We don't know yet if the 'new' ships we've detected joining the force in the system are new builds or repaired or upgraded ships," Adora pointed out. "Nor do we know if that's the last significant production site he has left - in fact, our analysts are sure that he has more production facilities hidden in his sphere of influence since he is so fond of compartmentalised force structures."

Biggs shook his head. "But they also agree that if Ba'al has such hidden facilities, they must be much smaller ones or we would have already faced much larger forces."

"Or they are in the process of being built up," Catra cut in. "Either way, we can't afford to lose the majority of our task force - it would cripple our offensive capability in the entire area."

"Only temporarily," Biggs disagreed. "I've seen the numbers; you'll have more ships built at the end of the year than all the ships of this task force put together, and you're also raising the crews for them."

“That doesn’t mean we’ll risk the task force to save time. People aren’t replaceable!” Adora snapped. The Admiral seemed awfully eager to risk huge numbers of Clones.

“We need to keep our optempo up,” Biggs said with a glare. “You can’t wage war if you want to keep our soldiers safe from any danger! That’s a sure way to lose the war! Soldiers die in war; that’s a fact.”

“We know better than you that soldiers die in war!” Glimmer scowled at him. “We’ve been fighting a war for decades.”

“We won’t sacrifice soldiers so some people can score points in politics,” Catra added.

“What are you insinuating?” Biggs snapped. “This is a purely military decision! We need to take out Ba’al as fast as possible, no matter the cost, or he’ll build up an even stronger force! Delaying our attack will only make the fight even harder once we launch the operation!”

That was a danger, Adora knew. She had written part of that analysis, after all. But that had been before Entrapta and Sam had discovered this system. “That would only be true if Ba’al’s could build up more forces in the time we need to reinforce the task force. And, so far, the data doesn’t show that.” She pointed at the system. “The output of those yards is not large enough to change the equations. And we haven’t discovered any hidden reinforcements in the vicinity either.”

“They could easily be hiding outside your sensor range!”

“Yes, but he doesn’t know our sensor range,” Adora said. “And he’s usually keeping his forces split up.”

“If this is his core system, he’ll call in everything once we attack,” Biggs argued.

“Which is why we need more ships for this,” Jack said. “I don’t want to see my people cut off on the ground because the fleet got

driven off."

"We can't wait and let him build up more ships."

"That's your opinion, and it's noted," Adora said. "But my decision is that we'll wait until the assigned reinforcements have arrived before we strike. We will need numerical superiority to overwhelm the defenders without sustaining too many losses. And we need a bit more time to prepare for their Death Glider swarms as well."

From the way Biggs blinked, he probably hadn't considered that.

Adora couldn't help thinking that maybe the Admiral should study the intel they had more than he should talk to his government - or their election managers.

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Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 4th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...and those unsettling - and unconfirmed - accusations, as tragic as they might be, do not change the fact that witchcraft was used against an American politician. If we do not take steps against this menace, every elected politician will be faced with the threat of being cursed like that. How can you trust a representative to follow his conscience when he has to fear for his very life anytime his decision might displease a terrorist? A democracy cannot work if we cannot trust our government to act without being influenced by outside powers like that!"

"So, Senator, does that mean you will vote for the proposed anti-corruption bill?"

"You cannot compare those two things! Witchcraft presents a clear and deadly danger to everyone, especially to public figures! This bill is far too radical - we don't need more laws and regulations; the existing ones are more than enough to keep corruption at bay!"

"What about guns? Guns are a lethal danger for everyone in the United States - especially for public figures. Do you support stricter regulations for guns as well?"

"Again, stop comparing apples and oranges! Guns are not the problem, people misusing them are the problem! We have millions of responsible, law-abiding gun owners. Compared to that number, the numbers of gun crimes are negligible! Witchcraft, on the other hand, is not nearly as common, yet has produced hundreds of victims already - and that only in this year!"

"Where do you get those numbers, Senator?

"I am privy to the latest FBI report about magical crimes."

"Oh? As it happens, I have received the same report. The vast majority of the incidents you mention have not been confirmed. In fact, the FBI's preliminary investigations in some of the cases strongly hint that most of those were attempts to hide a mundane crime or accident - or delusions by people caught in a second satanic panic. So I don't…"

"How dare you dismiss the pain and fear of the victims of witchcraft as delusions! Would you do the same if they were victims of sexual abuse?"

"Sexual abuse like the charges levelled against Mr Delan and Minister Smith, Senator?"

"None of those accusations have been proven in a court of law!"

"That's because the investigation has just been started. But I agree, maybe we shouldn't use accusations that were not proven in a court of law to persecute sorceresses in the USA."

"That's not the same! The danger to our country - our immortal souls - is far too great to hesitate here! We need to…"

Samantha Carter stopped the recording. To think she had been looking forward to catch up on the news from Earth after their last

foray into the heart of Ba'al's territory!

"I don't get it. This senator makes no sense," Entrapta said, shaking her head.

"He's a politician who was very invested in using the attack on Mr Delan to push his anti-magic policy and now has trouble adjusting to the revelations about the first victim's own crimes," Sam explained.

"No, no, I understand that. I think. We've had situations like that at the Princess Prom - I've read the paper George, Bow's dad, wrote about that even though I didn't see anything like it myself, though I only attended one prom so far." Entrapta shook her head. "Well, they weren't about such tragedies, but the ruler of the Scorpion Kingdom at the time was accusing the Princess of Plumeria of cheating while trading, and then the Princess of Salineas revealed that it was a corrupt sailor who was responsible, and everyone was too embarrassed to admit their mistakes. But, no, I meant the comment about the danger to their souls."

Sam grimaced for a moment. "That's a religious view, and religion is a very touchy and very personal subject for many people. It has been the cause of a lot of death and violence in the past, so we prefer not to argue over religion when we can avoid it." And she was very tired of trying to explain some of the more questionable arguments people had come up with in defence of their religion.

"Oh." Sam half-expected Entrapta to push on anyway and ask about another logical fallacy or hypocritical practice related to religion, but her friend nodded. "Alright. I'll ask Daniel when he arrives. He likes talking about that stuff."

Sam knew that already.

"And Sha're has a lot of insight into how similar your religions are to the ones controlled by the Goa'uld when you get past cosmetic differences. It's fascinating, actually, if you compare your churches and theirs. The parallels are so surprising!"

Sam hadn’t known that. And she was sure that a very high number of people on Earth would take exception to that. Possibly violently in some cases.

“Maybe we should ask Priest as well. He has studied Earth religions extensively so he can avoid their mistakes.”

And Sam knew that involving Priest in any such debate was not a good idea at all. Not if you wanted to avoid a conflict.

At least with the upcoming operation, they wouldn’t have time for such discussions for the next few weeks.

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Stargate Command, CFB Goose Bay, Newfoundland, Canada, August 5th, 2000

“...and we are here, in front of the Stargate, about to step through a wormhole to travel from Earth to a location thousands of lightyears away - a distance so long, human imagination cannot comprehend it. There, we will embark upon an Alliance warship and travel to the frontlines of the war against the Goa'uld. For the first time, journalists will not be reporting from planets that have been pacified, but directly from the front as it is being established. Stay tuned for a close-up view of how war is being conducted in space! This is Mark Bayley for CNN!”

Catra rolled her eyes at the reporter's fake excitement as he finished his recording and stepped away from the Stargate's ramp to make room for the next reporter. At least this one was from BBC - one of the non-American news companies that had sent reporters as well - and wasn't as sensationalist.

Of course, for civilians, stepping through a Stargate was a big deal, and they hadn't been told the actual distance or where they were going since that was classified information, but still, journalists had been covering the war before, and it wasn’t as if they'd let the the reporter drop on planets with the first wave. Jack had put his foot down when the Americans had wanted his

people to ‘play babysitter for the newshounds’, as he put it. And it wasn't as if the Stargate was currently active.

Oh, here came Bayley walking over. “Commander Catra? Do you mind a question?”

“Just Catra. I have no military rank,” she corrected him. His cameraman wasn't covering them, and he wasn't holding his microphone, so he wasn't trying to break the rules against recording without explicit permission and limitations.

“Ah.” He nodded, though she was sure he had known that in advance. At least he should have if he had properly prepared for this. “But you're effectively an officer in the Alliance, aren't you?”

She shrugged. “I help my friends when needed.”

“Both in staff positions and at the frontline, or so I've heard.”

She rolled her eyes. “As I said, I help my friends where and when needed.”

“Then, as someone not formally a member of the Alliance Command Council, what are your thoughts about this operation? According to our briefing, we'll be striking directly at the capital of Ba'al and the heart of his military-industrial complex.”

So, Bayley had paid attention to the briefing. Well, he'd be a bad journalist if he weren’t able to listen to others, and the Alliance had screened the reporters allowed on this trip quite thoroughly - Catra would know since she had vetoed two of them herself; they didn't need people spreading lies from bigots at the frontlines. Or anywhere else, in her opinion. “We’re attacking one of Ba'al's bases,” she replied. “Anything further is classified information.” Technically, that they were attacking Ba'al was classified as well, but the reporters had been read in so they knew what kind of Goa'uld they were facing and what kind of conditions they could expect in his territory.

“Yes, that's the official line and I am not going to use this in my reports. But is it true that we're invading the capital of his realm? The first time Alliance forces will be hitting a core planet of the enemy?”

So, that was the US government’s angle here to get as much good PR out of this: Hype up the target as much as possible. As if this was a race to Berlin. Well, it was a race, but that was even more classified. “We don't have a map of Ba'al's territory with all his bases,” she replied and flashed her fangs.

“Ah.” Bayley nodded with a smile as if she had actually revealed anything. He probably thought she had confirmed his question without doing so overtly. Well, his fault. “So, have you already decided how you will be ‘helping your friends’ on this operation?

By talking to annoying reporters so they didn't annoy Adora or Glimmer, she thought. That's why she was keeping an eye on this. “Wherever I am needed.”

“But will you be fighting with SG-1 again, as you’ve had in the past?”

“SG-1 was dissolved when the team members left Stargate Command,” she corrected him.

“Of course. But ‘the team formerly known as SG-1’ is a bit of a mouthful, isn’t it?” The way he smiled was probably the reason he had been chosen for this - naive girls and boys would likely fall for it.

Catra wasn’t naive or interested in men. She sighed. “Mr Bayley, you cannot predict anything like that in war. It's far too fluid for that. I might stay back on a frigate and simply watch the battles munching some fish sticks,” she lied. She’d only do that if Adora stayed back on the flagship as well, and everyone knew Adora wouldn't do that. Certainly not when there was a chance that Ba'al himself was present in the system.

“But do you expect to fight with the Alliance Special Forces led by General O'Neill on the ground?”

She rolled her eyes. “As I said, I don't expect anything. We can't predict anything yet. And if we could, I couldn't tell you. Not without having you locked up afterwards to maintain operational security.” She flashed her fangs again.

This time, he seemed to get the message and nodded as his smile slipped slightly. “I see. Thank you for the talk, Catra.”

Of course, the other reporters - an even dozen - hadn't missed this and were now descending on her.

Great. Catra fixed her smile and prepared to repeat her lines until the idiots got the message as well.

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Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 6th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“General O'Neill! Mark Bayley, CNN. A word?”

Jack O'Neill almost made an about face and headed back into his cabin when he heard the reporter call out - reporters, he corrected himself when he saw that Bayley was followed by two more of them. But he had been told by the President himself to be nice to the journalists - to go out of his way, in fact, to ‘accommodate’ them as long as it didn't hinder the operation.

Of course, being late for breakfast could hinder the operation if that meant Jack might be missing a critical problem in planning… Naw. That would be too obvious. Even the dumbest reporter amongst the bunch would see through it, and Jack didn't doubt that at least some would take offence and develop a grudge against him and his friends.

And his friends didn't deserve that. Daniel had suffered through a smear campaign already, back when his - ultimately proven - theory had been laughed at, and Jack knew that some Navy

pukes were just waiting for the chance to use Carter as a scapegoat for their own failures in the Constitution II-class mess. And Teal'c was an obvious target as the former First Prime of Apophis.

So he smiled - if a bit toothily- and nodded. “Sure. I'm heading to the mess, so feel free to tag along.” If he could field their questions during breakfast, he wouldn’t lose too much time. And if he needed to think about a question, taking a bite or a sip would help.

“Great!” Bayley beamed at him. “So, how does it feel to be the highest-ranking ground commander in the operation? Some experts have criticised your habit of leading from the front.”

Jack grinned. He had expected that question. “Well, they're used to a different war than we're fighting here. I can't make the big decisions if I don't have the necessary information. Sometimes, that means I can't stay back on a ship in orbit but need to be on the spot.”

“One would expect that with modern, advanced technology, you didn't need to be on the spot,” another reporter - he had a southern drawl - commented. “Chris Evans, NBC.”

“Even then, there'll be delays and limited information,” Jack replied. And jamming, though that was classified information. “You never get the full picture unless you're there.”

“But as the general in charge, don’t you need to see the full picture of the entire front, not just a single part of it? There have been concerns that you're in the habit of acting like a squad leader instead of a general, a habit carried over from your time at Stargate Command,” Bayley asked.

Jack kept smiling despite his growing annoyance - he really needed his coffee and breakfast. Weren't those journalists supposed to produce a puff piece for the election campaign? “At Stargate Command, we were not fighting nearly as often as

people think. Most of the time, we were exploring. If you're making First Contact with an alien civilisation, you really don't want that to be handled by a second lieutenant fresh out of West Point and a bunch of privates."

"But you're fighting a war now," the third journalist pointed out. "Cyril Foster, ABC."

"Yes, but as I said, it depends on the situation. Sometimes, you can handle everything from your command centre back in orbit," Jack replied. "The British-built fleet transports have great command and control facilities, by the way." Take that, Navy pukes! "But sometimes, you need to be in front to do your job."

"Like the princesses?" Southern Drawl Evans looked at him.

"The princesses are on the frontlines because that's usually where they can use their powers to best effect," Jack said. Ah, there was the door to the mess! Coffee, here we come!

Two Clones stepped to the side when he entered, the journalists in tow. He spotted Daniel, Sha're, Teal'c and Carter at a table - they had left a spot free for him! Unfortunately, there wasn't enough room for the reporters. Damn.

"But what about the criticism that they are neglecting their other duties as commanders?" Bayley asked.

That was aimed at him, Jack knew. He grinned widely at the man. "They do their duty while fighting at the front. That's how it works in the Princess Alliance. That's how they beat the Horde and Horde Prime. You could say their way has been tested in combat."

The smell of coffee hit his nose and Jack barely resisted the urge to get a cup, down it, and refill it before grabbing food. But he managed to limit himself to a sip before loading up on bacon, eggs and hash browns.

Fortunately for them, none of the reporters criticised his food choices by citing some nutritional experts or whatever. That would

have been too much for his temper. He needed his calories to stomach those questions.

Besides, after being zapped by She-Ra's magic healing beam, Jack was as healthy as a twenty-year-old, he could handle all the cholesterol.

Not that he'd tell the journalists that - if it got out that She-Ra could do that, things would get even more complicated back on Earth.

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Adora double-checked if there were any journalists in the room before starting the planning meeting. There shouldn't be any, of course - this was the flag room of the frigate, a restricted area - but with the way some reporters had been following people around, it was better to be sure. If only to avoid giving Catra - or Glimmer - an excuse to mistake a journalist for a spy.

Seeing no one - Catra wasn't looking as if she was about to pounce someone either - she nodded and addressed the room: "Alright! We've got the latest intel and we now have a comprehensive picture of the target system's defenses. Though we still don't know the exact composition and technology the enemies use."

She pointed at the holoprojection above the centre of the table. "Even if the Ha'taks had only been upgraded with beam cannons, like the ones we've fought before, they would present a formidable force against a frontal assault when working with the lighter ships and the swarm of Death Gliders with clone or bot pilots. Depending on the tactics they use, they could inflict significant losses." And if they had learnt anything from their past battles against Ba'al, it was that Ba'al was a cunning foe whose forces adapted various tactics.

"And if they have upgraded the Ha'taks further? Or the lighter ships?" Captain Baker asked.

“Heavy casualties. We don't have sufficient defences against suicide attacks by Death Gliders carrying enhanced ordnance,” Adora told him. “Adapting our ship's anti-fighter defences to compensate would take too long for this operation.” And would strain their fleet train. “So, we're working on an alternative solution that can be done with our current supplies and in time.” She looked at Entrapta and Sam.

Entrapta nodded. “Yes! We've got some ideas, but we need a bit more data - or, rather, we need more contingencies in case we're wrong. We've been probing their networks, but we didn't crash or hack anyone yet so we don't alert the enemy to our presence.”

“We are confident that we have a decisive advantage in the field of electronic warfare,” Sam added. “But as past experiences prove, we can only leverage that for a limited time before the enemy adapts. And we have to assume that they expect us to jam their communications as we did before.”

“Which is why we will have to maximise the impact when we crash their networks,” Adora said. They would have to use jamming tactics anyway, but they couldn't depend on it. “We did manage to confirm that they have ship yards producing ships in the system, though most of them seemed to be working on Death Gliders and a new type.”

The system was replaced by a projection of a Death Glider and a Ha'tak.

Sam stood and started explaining. “Observation revealed that the Ha'taks being built here are what we have dubbed ‘carrier variants’, sacrificing most of their firepower for the capacity to carry significantly higher numbers of Death Gliders.”

“That means they plan to use Death Gliders as their main force in the battle,” Jack commented.

Sam nodded. “Yes, sir. Analysis came to the same conclusion. The fleet being gathered here will rely on swarm attacks by massed

Death Gliders. That means the threat of suicide attacks is high, given Ba'al's willingness to sacrifice his own forces."

Adora clenched her teeth. Ba'al was a monster! But he was a skilled enemy.

"Does that mean he's using bots in his fighters? Even with clones, he would have a hard time replacing losses, wouldn't he?" Baker asked.

"We haven't been able to confirm either hypothesis yet," Sam replied.

"Bots would need less supplies, but they are more vulnerable to jamming," Entrapta said. "They rely on sensors. Clones would be able to pick their targets even without any working sensors, as long as they are close enough for visual contact. But! Whether Ba'al uses bots or clones, setting up a pipeline for either would have taken more time than he should have had since we first used the hyperspace jammer on his forces. So, even if he picked clones, it doesn't have to be a reaction to our jamming technology - he just could have been lucky."

"Since he has heavily invested in cloning technology for a variety of reasons, we are leaning toward him using clones as pilots," Sam added with a slight grimace.

Adora nodded. No matter how they dealt with the swarm, they would probably be killing a lot of people - people who didn't know any better since they were made and raised to serve Ba'al as pilots. Looking at the others and their grim expressions, she knew they shared her feelings. It was a horrible situation, but they didn't have any alternative - they had to defeat Ba'al to put a stop to this or even more people would suffer and die for the Goa'uld.

The holoprojection changed back to the system and zoomed in on a world.

"The space-based defences are centred on this planet. The ships are augmented by a few orbital satellites, but those are a

negligible force compared to Ba'al's fleet," Sam went on. "However, the surface of the planet itself - the main world of the system - has also been fortified, with ample anti-orbital and anti-air defences. And they are centred on this:"

The holoprojection changed again.

"That looks like a palace," Jack said.

"Yes." Daniel pushed his glasses up. "It's not a classic Goa'uld style, but the basic concepts and layout are still the same. It might be a recent construction incorporating Horde technology from the ground up. Coupled with the symbols, we think there's a high probability that this is Ba'al's main palace - his headquarters."

"I doubt he would waste so many defences on a palace if it weren't to protect him," Jack said. "He seems more pragmatic and would probably protect his shipyards instead."

"Unless this is a double-bluff and this is a distraction to protect the shipyards," Sha're suggested.

"That would still leave the shipyards' defences weaker than they could be - and open to attacks by equally pragmatic enemies," Jack said.

"And sacrificing what looks to be his main palace would still cause a loss of face if it was known by his rivals," Daniel said.

"If it was known," Sha're repeated. "Ba'al has been able to keep a lot of secrets from everyone, even us."

Adora nodded. "We'll be ready for a trap or any other surprise. But we won't let that stop us." They couldn't. "Now, for the ground assault…"

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Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 7th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Major Carter! Mark Bayley, CNN. A word, if you please?”

Samantha Carter stopped and rolled her eyes, grimacing, before she pasted a polite smile on her face and turned to the journalist - Mark Bayley. “I am sorry, but I am in the middle of a crucial project.”

“For this operation? Or for procurement? According to my sources, you’ve been crucial for the much-maligned Constitution II-class design.”

Sam tensed. Sam didn’t see any recording device, but that didn’t preclude a hidden microphone. And she knew she should just tell the journalist that she was busy and leave him standing, but… She wasn’t about to get portrayed as responsible for that abomination of a ship design! “I’ve been called in to deal with some of its flaws, but I have not been involved in its design otherwise.” And it wouldn’t be some unholy attempt to mate a carrier and a gunship.

“Oh? I was told that you were working on all its key systems - engines, shields and weapons.”

“I was called in to work on some of the flaws that were detected in the ships during testing,” Sam told him. She had already said that.

“There were flaws in all three key systems?” Bayley seemed surprised. So, he didn’t have internal sources - he would be aware of how bad the design was otherwise.

“No new design is perfect,” Sam replied. As much as she wanted, she couldn’t reveal just how many flaws the Constitution II-class had - or how bad the design had been from the start.

“But the problems of this class are much more serious - and numerous - than others. The British Flower II-class, for example, is already in active service. I’ve been on one during a patrol in the Solar System.”

Between Third Fleet and the spy bot network, there was no need for the corvettes to patrol the system. But it was a good way to train up the crews. "Yes, but that's a corvette, a smaller and simpler design than a frigate."

"Yes, so I've heard - though one of the criticisms aimed at the frigate is that the design is too complicated to be practical and that it would better serve as a testbed for future projects instead of a ship of the line."

"I cannot comment on that decision; I am a physicist and scientist, I am not responsible for procuring our ships," Sam said.

"But you build them - or you fix them. You've been spotted several times in the Norfolk yards."

Sam really shouldn't have stopped to talk to the press, orders to cooperate within reason be damned! On the other hand, if the Navy was trying to use her as a scapegoat for their own failures, this was her chance to set the public record straight. "Yes, I have been called in to deal with problems, and as long as my work for the Alliance is not affected too much, I have lent a hand." That was the third time she had told him the same thing!

"Your work for the Alliance… you've been working for Stargate Command as one of their most capable scientists. Yet you regularly saw combat. Do you feel that sending our best scientists out to fight in the field, so to speak, is a good policy?"

Not that again! "Sometimes - quite often, actually - you need a scientist in the field to deal with problems you encounter," she replied. "Without Princess Entrapta's personal contribution, Horde Prime might not have been defeated."

"Does that mean you expect Ba'al to be as dangerous as Horde Prime?"

"It is never a good idea to underestimate your enemy." She tilted her head slightly to the side. "Anything else is classified."

“But…”

“Good day!”

She turned and walked away, her strides just a bit longer than normal. Entrapta was waiting for her.

They had to figure out how to deal with Ba’al’s Death Glider swarm, and the longer they took, the more dangerous it would become.

Fortunately, they had a few ideas already.

Unfortunately, they still had to figure out if they were practical - and if so, how to implement them.

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Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 8th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Catra rotated the holoprojection above the table and looked at the units on the other side of the target planet again. It wasn't a real-time feed, but it was close enough. The capital ships stuck close to the planet while the lighter units formed a screen around them, not around the planet. Standard formations, too, with the Tel'tak's forming the outer perimeter and the Al'keshs the inner, ready to form attack squadrons to pounce on enemy capital ships.

The Death Gliders, on the other hand, were split. Part of them - the smaller part - were circling the formations on regular combat air patrol routes. The vast majority of them, though, were basically covering the entire system like a Goa'uld miniature version of the spy bot network. Dense patterns in the inner system, where the planet with Ba'al's palace was located, and thinner patterns in the outer system, past a gas giant. But still dense enough that slipping any force through some gaps without getting pounced by a swarm of them was impossible.

Sure, you could feint with part of your forces, draw them in, but that would be hard on the probing force - and they had a lot of

fighters so it wouldn't actually strip the rest of the system bare. Not if Ba'al's commanders were semi-competent - and Catra knew better than to assume the enemy was incompetent.

The sheer numbers of fighters also made a surprise attack by dropping out of hyperspace right next to the capital ships of the enemy too dangerous. With the sensor data from the spy bot network, the Alliance forces had managed to pull off such manoeuvres successfully, but against upgraded Ha'taks and possibly upgraded Tel'taks and Al'keshs? Supported by swarms of Death Gliders on suicide attacks? Entrapta and Sam had already confirmed with a few scans when patrols came too close to a spy bot that the Death Gliders were carrying bombs - inside the crafts, not on pylons, and they hadn’t been modified with bomb bays.

They had replaced the weapon officer’s seat with the bomb.

It would be a brutal brawl straight out of the gate, so to speak, and the Alliance task force would take heavy losses even if they arrived in perfect formations ready to repel waves of suicide attackers. Which they wouldn't. Travelling through hyperspace would disrupt their formations - not too much, but it would tell in such a situation - and they would have to launch fighters under fire, unlike the enemy. They could still win if they managed to fend off the Death Gliders, but Catra was sure the task force would need to be rebuilt afterwards.

“No matter how you look at it, it doesn't look good,” Adora commented next to her.

“No, it doesn't,” Catra agreed. In the Horde, she would have ordered a frontal assault anyway. The Horde had outnumbered the Princess Alliance and could replace their losses more easily. Especially if she used bots to breach the enemy lines and bear the brunt of their fire. And then use the rest of the bots to blunt the enemy counterattack.

But she wasn't in the Horde any more. She wasn't like that any more. She wouldn't send people to their death like that.

“They still cycle the Death Gliders through,” she stated the obvious to help herself focus on the situation at hand instead of her past. “None of them stay in space so long, only bots could pilot them.” Entrapta and Sam had observed that straight away.

“Yes.”

That didn't mean that the fighter pilots were cloned people. Ba'al could simply want to keep the Death Gliders refueled so they were always ready for combat and wouldn’t be caught with their tanks half-empty. Or he wanted any spies to assume the Death Gliders had cloned pilots - the bastard was tricky like that.

But Catra was betting that Ba'al used cloned pilots. They would be able to handle extensive jamming better than bots - even indoctrinated clones were better at adapting to changing circumstances in a battle than bots, if they were cut off from orders. And, she added with clenched teeth, Ba'al probably preferred living pilots for suicide attacks. It would impress his enemies more than bots blowing themselves up. His Goa'uld rivals would see how devoted his followers were, and the Alliance would be horrified by it. Catra didn’t think it would keep any Alliance crew from doing their best to shoot the Death Gliders down in the middle of combat, but the knowledge that you were killing brainwashed people who hadn't been alive longer than a few months wouldn't be good for long-term morale.

Not that the plans Sam and Entrapta had come up with would be any better. They suggested infiltrating the enemy system and inserting a virus into the carrier-Ha’taks and letting it spread to the Death Gliders so they could disable the fighters when they attacked. That would prevent suicide attacks. But the bombs would have a manual trigger - Ba'al was the type to insist on that - and they already knew he didn't want his followers to let themselves get captured, and so the pilots would still blow themselves up. Probably when the Alliance was trying to recover them. Alternatively, they could hijack the Death Glider command and control network to send the swarms against Ba'al's own ships - like every Goa'uld System Lord, he would have plans to deal with

rebels and traitors in his own ranks, so that wouldn't be questioned - but sending so many brainwashed people to their deaths… Adora would blame herself for it, and Catra couldn't let her do that.

“I don't see any alternative,” Adora said. “Everything I think of leads to more deaths on our side and still kills all of them.” She sounded resigned.

Catra knew that. But she wasn't about to let Adora give such an order. She couldn't - it would hurt her love too much. If only she could just snap her fingers and… Her eyes widened.

“I've got an idea!” A stupid, dangerous idea, but one that might not see Adora ordering the death of thousands of brainwashed followers of Ba'al.

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The Election Campaign Part 3

Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 8th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"...and as the authorities confirmed that James Delan has succumbed to what has been identified as a magical curse, the recently confirmed presidential candidate of Mr Delan's party has called on everyone to pray for Mr Delan's family and to abstain from trying to weaponise the tragedy for political purposes. Darryl Miller, NBC."

"Thank you Darryl! Now, of course, a presidential candidate would say that when one of his most important supporters has been implicated in such a scandal. But it feels more than a bit hypocritical when his own party has been weaponising the magical attack on Mr Delan for their own goals practically from the point when he was loaded into an ambulance, wouldn't you agree?"

"I certainly would, Keith. I think we all remember how much certain circles tried to use this tragedy to get magic regulated in the US. In fact, Mr Delan's family is apparently considering a lawsuit because they claim if not for being influenced by the constant calls against magic, they would have consented to letting a sorceress treat Mr Delan since the doctors in charge of his treatment recommended that course of action."

"That's very surprising if we consider their own statements following the attack, Darryl."

"Indeed, Keith. In other news from Philadelphia, the suspect for the magical attack is still being detained and her lawyers have filed a complaint that her treatment is inhumane - apparently, she has been kept sedated for the whole time she has been detained so far, out of fear she might be using magic against the guards to escape. The ACLU has already stated that they are supporting a lawsuit to end this policy."

"As you can see, folks, the attack on Mr Delan is still causing consequences that reach far beyond Pennsylvania. We're looking forward to seeing when the Supreme Court will weigh in on this matter, and…"

Jack O'Neill pushed a button and closed the window on his computer. "I just wanted to catch up on the sports results," he muttered. "And all I get is this affair."

"Well, Jack, it's only expected. One of the most important supporters of a presidential candidate was not only attacked - fatally, now - with magic but also revealed to be a child abuser, and that just when the election campaign is ramping up. Every news organisation will focus on this." Daniel shrugged. "And as we just heard, the ramifications of this event keep growing in importance. This could be a leading case for handling magical murder and detaining suspects with magic power - and that, of course, would influence the political consequences of the attack."

"I thought lawsuits took a long time to be decided," Bow said. "Wouldn't the political consequences manifest before that?"

"Unless the religious fanatics somehow get a majority in congress to support their bills, it'll be a long time before any bill aimed at regulating magic will be voted on. There are many steps bills have to pass before a vote happens," Daniel explained. "And yes, the delay is the point - it's generally not a good idea to enact laws in the heat of the moment," he added when Glimmer opened her mouth.

The princess closed her mouth with a scowl, and Jack sniggered. One rant against democracy cut down before it could get going. Nice work, Daniel!

"Sometimes you can't wait for months or years, though - you have to act immediately to fix something," Adora cut in.

"That's generally the purview of the executive - the President, in America," Daniel told her.

Glimmer snorted. “Your elected princess, you mean.”

“It’s not quite the same. There are a lot of checks and balances that prevent the President from becoming a monarch,” Daniel said.

“I know,” Glimmer replied. “But effectively, you still need someone to take charge in a crisis. And if you trust them to do so in a crisis, why not trust them when things are going well? If you didn’t trust them, you wouldn’t have voted for them, right?”

“The idea is that no single person or faction can have too much power,” Daniel explained.

“Yes, we know that. But what do you do if you can’t get anything done because everyone keeps blocking everyone else?” Glimmer shook her head again.

“What do you do if you get a bad princess?” Jack shot back. “A bad president can be voted out of office. How do you get rid of a bad monarch without launching a coup?”

“Sooner or later, a bad ruler is ousted because their neighbours get involved,” Glimmer said.

“So, it’s not a bloody revolution but a bloody invasion?” Jack asked.

“Yes, like you did in Germany and Japan,” Glimmer smiled far too sweetly.

“Which weren’t democracies at the time,” Daniel pointed out.

But at least Germany had been a democracy for a decade or so before, Jack knew. Not that he would mention that. Glimmer and the other princesses already had a bad opinion of democracy, and the latest events back home hadn’t done anything to improve them. “So,” he spoke up instead. “What’s that new and possible stupid plan you’ve mentioned?”

Glimmer exchanged glances with Adora and Catra.

“It’s not a stupid plan,” Adora said.

“It is,” Catra cut in.

“It’s your idea!” Glimmer blurted out.

“So I’d know. It’s stupid. And dangerous. But I don’t see anyone with a better idea.” Catra shrugged. “Anyway, the idea is to send a covert strike team down to the planet, infiltrate the palace, nab Ba’al…”

“I’m liking this plan already!” Jack said with a grin.

“...and replace him with a body double - or a doppelgänger,” Catra finished.

Jack frowned. “Are you planning to let a Tok’ra take over the clone we captured?” That would run counter to pretty much every Alliance principle. The princesses had insisted that clones were people and had to be treated as such. “Or… doppelgänger?” Hadn’t they mentioned some shapeshifter everyone was afraid would escape Etheria if the gate weren’t strictly controlled? What was their name again? Something with ‘double’...

“Double Trouble,” Glimmer confirmed his suspicion.

*****

The Enchanted Grotto, Etheria, August 10th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“Ah! The Enchanted Grotto! The place for every successful and famous rogue to mingle with their peers! You’ll never find a greater collection of the most cunning scoundrels in all of Etheria!”

“Ugh. You sound as if you’re proud of being a regular here!”

“My love! Such fame and prestige is merely the result of my love for ADVENTURE! But what kind of man would I be, what kind of sailor, if I did not accept the fame my deeds earned me?”

“The humble and honest kind?”

“Ack! You wound me, my love!”

“Don’t tempt me!”

While Sea Hawk and Mermista either flirted or quarrelled - maybe a bit of both - Adora looked around. The underwater club did look impressive with its huge windows granting everyone an excellent view of the underwater landscape? Seascape? Though the guests didn’t look as impressive as Sea Hawk had made them sound - most were eyeing Adora and her friends warily.

“Guess they haven’t forgotten that you trashed the place last time you visited,” Catra said. She sounded nonchalant, but Adora could see how being underwater made her nervous - her tail was swishing back and forth much faster than usual, and she was flexing her claws unconsciously. And her fur was bristling a little, as Adora felt on the arm she had hooked into her love’s elbow.

“That was an unfortunate accident,” Sea Hawk said as he walked straight towards the bar. “If we had intended to wreck the place, we would have set it on fire! Bartender! My good woman, an ale for me, and a pina colada for my love, Princess Mermista, the Mistress of the sea!”

The bartender didn’t smile and seemed to pay more attention to Adora and Mermista than to Sea Hawk for a few seconds before she gruffly asked: “What’s a pina colada?”

Sea Hawk beamed at her. “Oh, you don’t know? It’s one of the most famous drinks from Earth! It’s easy to make, you just need…”

Adora tuned the recipe out as she looked around again. “I don’t see them,” she whispered. Double rouble could be anyone

amongst the gathered smugglers and pirates. Maybe they should have asked Prince Peekablue to come with them instead of merely pointing out where they could find he shapeshifter…

Catra smirked. “They can change their form but they can’t change their mind.” She looked around for a moment, scanning the room. Then she cocked her head, staring at a goatman in a very flashy suit.

“And there they are!” Catra beamed and walked up to the man, Melog - the one who had actually spotted the shapeshifter - trailing behind her. “Hey, Double Trouble! Just the criminal we’re looking for!”

“*You* brought the princesses here?” the woman Double Trouble had been talking to spat. “Are you daft?”

The man gasped and laid a hand on his heart. “Why, I have no idea why they are here - or why they mistake me for someone else!”

“Save it, Double Trouble, we know it’s you. Really? Returning to the Grotto? Where’s your creativity?” Catra reached out and grabbed the man at the scruff of their neck. Adora saw that her claws were peaking out again - and pricking the throat’s skin. “Let’s have a private talk!”

The goatman froze for a moment, looking frightened, then suddenly relaxed and pouted. “Must you ruin my performance? I had them eating out of my hand!”

“Why you!” The woman raised her hand to slap or hit them, but Adora stepped between the two.

“Please don’t hit them.”

The woman paled and took a quick step back. “I’m sorry, Princess! Please excuse me.” She hurried away - towards the exit.

And she wasn't the only one, Adora noted - the Grotto was emptying. Half the guests had already left, or so it seemed.

Her friends must have left a really bad impression the last time they had visited.

"...and then you decorate it with a slice of pineapple!"

And they weren't making a good impression today either - the bartender was glaring at Sea Hawk. "I don't have a 'malibu' either - no, don't tell me the recipe!"

"It's coconut flavoured rum!"

"I said don't tell me!"

"But how can you mix the drink for my love if you don't know the recipe?"

"We don't serve princesses!"

"But… that's discrimination!"

"Sea Hawk! Mermista!" Adora called out. "We're leaving!"

"Finally!"

"But we didn't get our drinks yet!" Sea Hawk complained.

Mermista scoffed. "We can have drinks when we have our private talk with Double Trouble, Sea Hawk. We'll probably need them."

"I didn't agree to a private talk!" Double Trouble protested.

"No one asked you to." Catra flashed her fangs but didn't release her grip on their neck.

"I'm not saying anything without a lawyer!"

Catra snorted. "We're not on Earth. And it's not that kind of talk."

“I think you’re enjoying this far too much, Kitty!”

Adora thought so too. Especially looking at Melog’s colour. Not that she would say that, of course.

And, if she was honest, she also enjoyed unnerving Double Trouble. At least a little. They had caused a lot of trouble, after all, and she didn’t think playing nice would send the right message to them.

Adora and her friends wanted their help, but they wouldn’t let them run wild in exchange.

*****

Royal Palace, Bright Moon, Etheria, August 10th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“You went to all that trouble just to have me sit through a presentation in the palace? You could have just asked! Or… did you call me in because you need some advice about style and panache? Because those are truly dreadful clothes, girlfriend!”

Samantha Carter was a career officer and scientist. How she looked, especially in uniform, did not define her. And Double Trouble may have acted confidently, but it was clear that they were here against their will - Catra had dragged them into the room at clawpoint, and the door was not only guarded but locked.

And yet, the blatant disparaging of her uniform annoyed her. It was a slight against every member of the Alliance forces. Against everyone was willing to risk their lives to defeat the Goa'uld.

So, she didn't ignore the barb. “Clearly, our standards differ.”

“You have standards? Could have fooled me! How can you wear such drab clothes? Even Kitty Cat and Princess Sword, who still wear their old uniforms, have more style than that - at least their uniforms don't look like the good old ‘one size doesn't fit anyone’ style. No wonder you guard the gate so tightly, Earth's people

must be desperate to visit our tailors!” Double Trouble shook her head and flashed her a very toothy grin.

“Yeah, as if we believe you haven't devoured every last scrap of information about Earth's culture you could get.” Glimmer scoffed.

“You've been following me? A royal fan! I am honoured, Queen Glimmer!” Double Trouble bowed, then sat down in a pointedly casual manner on her seat. “So, what kind of presentation is this?”

Catra rolled her eyes and stood behind her, lightly touching her back with one claw. “The kind you pay attention to.”

“Oh, stuff it. You want me bad enough to personally travel underwater, you won't hurt me for being me, Kitty Cat.” Double Trouble grinned again, and Sam was reminded of the Unas they had met.

“Oh, we have alternatives,” she told them. Loki actually had had a proposal ready to clone a body double and use a synthetic symbiote and the right amount of Naquadah traces to pass for a Ba’al. Sam hadn't liked to tell him that the Alliance didn't *create people* for a task that needed doing. And that was before she had realised that he had planned to use Asgard technology to move a trained infiltrator's consciousness into it. Clearly, he needed more oversight again. And the Alliance needed better operational security - Loki hadn't been cleared for that knowledge in the first place.

“None as good as the original, girlfriend!”

Sam smiled. She was familiar with that kind of act - she had met her share of blenders in the force and, of course, in academics. “That remains to be seen.”

“Yeah,” Glimmer said. “Don't kid yourself - it would be nice if you helped us, but we don't *need* you.”

“But you want me so badly, you go to all this trouble for little old Double Trouble!” They leaned forward, and suddenly, they were no longer looking like a humanoid lizard, but like Sam. “Because I'm the best,” Sam heard herself say as the double's body language shifted as well - it was like looking at a recording of herself.

“Your help could save thousands of people,” Adora told them.

“Wow, you are desperate then!”

Sam never grinned like that, though.

“Thousands of enemies,” Catra corrected them.

Double Trouble shrugged - did Sam really look like that when she did it, or had the shapeshifter added a bit more to it? She would have to check that with a mirror. “That's the same thing for you folks. You want to save everyone.”

“You say that like it's a bad thing,” Glimmer shot back. Then she bared her teeth, “It's not. Imagine if we didn't.”

“Well, you would…” Catra's claws closed lightly around their neck - Sam couldn't help wondering if the shapeshifter could counter an attempt to strangle them by changing shape - and Double Trouble grimaced. “You consider little old me an enemy?”

“That remains to be seen. We know you've been trying to get through the gate,” Glimmer said.

“Everyone on Etheria has. It's the one big thing - the gateway to the stars! Can you blame me for wanting to see new worlds? Imagine the performances they could inspire!”

Glimmer snorted. “That's what we're afraid of.”

Adora cleared her throat. “Listen to the presentation. Then you can decide if you want to help us or not.”

Double Trouble made a point of looking around while rubbing their neck - Sam wished they would change back and stop using her appearance - and coughed. “The same way I could decide whether I’d attend this meeting or not?”

“That was just to show that we can find you wherever you are and whatever form you use.”

Sam also didn't pout like that. It made her look far too… unprofessional. “I shouldn't have used Peekablue's form. No sense of humour, that guy. He should be flattered that I helped his reputation,” Double Trouble said.

“Prince Peakblue wasn't very amused to hear that he's supposedly singing in a bar catering to pirates and other criminals,” Glimmer said. “Or so I heard.”

“You'd be surprised how many princesses frequent the place, Sparkles. Why, I alone have met half a dozen of them when I was there!”

“Ha ha.” Glimmer snorted again, but Sam wasn't quite sure Double Trouble was kidding - royalty going slumming wasn't unheard of on earth. “Let's get on with the briefing.”

“Oh, now it's a briefing? That takes me back to the war! Did you work for the Horde before?”

Sam didn't roll her eyes. She was an officer, and above that. But she *really* wished Double Trouble would stop copying her - it was unnerving. At least the General wasn’t here; the twin jokes he'd make…

*****

“...and that's the situation.”

Catra had watched Double Trouble during Sam's briefing. They had kept Sam's form and exaggerated their reactions as expected, and she was sure that they had faked a number of their tells -

Double Trouble wasn't so dangerous because they could shapeshift, but because they were the best actor she had seen, at least in person. But Catra also knew Double Trouble better than most who had the bad luck of meeting them. And she thought they were intrigued. Though that might be her being biased - it was Catra's plan, after a..

“So…” Double Trouble leaned back, stretching and pushing their chest out in a way that Sam would never do. “...you want me to sneak into an alien warlord's palace, on another world, and impersonate them so I can order their army to surrender?” Their grin also was far too toothy for Sam.

“Yes.” Adora nodded.

Catra was sure that the offer to impersonate an alien ruler was almost irresistible to Double Trouble. They craved drama and attention, but most of all, they had an ego that rivaled Horde Prime. The only questions were what they would demand in return. Because no matter what Double Trouble might claim, they were as much a mercenary - or a fraud - as they were a performer.

“And you think I can imitate them convincingly based on the few recordings you have, and the clone you captured a while ago.” Double Trouble cocked their head to the side.

“You're the best, aren't you?” Glimmer said.

“Of course, Sparkles!” Double Trouble snorted. “You won't find anyone else who's even near my league. That's why you went to all that trouble to grab little Double Trouble.” She flashed her teeth again. “You are desperate.”

“You are the most convenient solution,” Catra spoke up behind them and grinned when she saw them twitch. “We have alternatives.”

But they remained as smug as ever. “None as good as I am, or you'd not be talking to me.”

“None as convenient as you - as long as you play ball,” Catra corrected them.

“Sure, sure. You only need to convince his clone to help you. His clone who thinks he’s the real Ba’al and hates you. And you would have to provide them with the cloned host to pull this off.” Double Trouble scoffed. “Next, you'll be telling me you're planning to blow up the planet.”

They sounded far too smug. It didn't take that much to come to that conclusion - Sam's briefing had been thorough, and with soldiers going on home leave after missions, people knew what the Goa'uld were like. And Double Trouble was familiar with the Princess Alliance.

“We don't think that the situation requires the deployment of weapons of mass destruction on a planetary scale,” Sam said, in a tone as if she were talking about the weather.

Once more, Double Trouble twitched just a tiny bit.

“We don't need you to win this battle,” Glimmer said. “We need you to win this battle without killing thousands of brainwashed clones and indoctrinated Jaffa.”

“How considerate of you,” Double Trouble shrugged. “Whatever your reasons, you need me. So, let's talk about compensation!” They leaned forward again, putting their hands on the table. “You cost me a nice payout when you wrecked my performance. And you want me to risk my life against a sadist alien prince who will take over my body if he catches me.”

“He won't catch you. You're the best, aren't you?” Glimmer retorted.

“Anyone can get lucky. Even you guys managed to find me. Who knows what those aliens can do?”

“We'll take out Ba'al first,” Adora said. “You just have to come along and then impersonate him when we have him.”

“We've got experience with that kind of mission,” Catra added. “No matter where he is, we can find him and take him out.”

Double Trouble scowled. “Peekablue didn't rat me out because I used his appearance, huh? He threw in with you for good, but you're keeping it a secret so people won't expect him. I'd say you're smarter than I thought, princess. But that's your doing, Kitty Cat, hm?” They looked over her shoulder at Catra.

Catra flashed her fangs in response. They weren't as smart as they thought they were. Peekablue hadn't joined them - and if he had, the Alliance would never let him get close to any planet under a Goa'uld's control, much less one ruled by Ba'al; the guy wouldn't be able to handle the horrors he would see.

Double Trouble scoffed and turned back to Adora. “I want a spaceship and the promise that you won't track me down again.”

“Forget it!” “Not in your dreams!” Glimmer and Catra spoke in unison.

“We won't let you lose on the galaxy,” Adora said.

“Come on! What's a bit of fun down the line compared to all those poor people being killed?”

“Playing with people's lives isn't fun,” Glimmer told her.

“Oh, but it is. Have you ever tried it?” Double Trouble grinned. “Princesses do it all the time but call it ruling!”

Glimmer scowled. “That's not the same! We do the best we can for our people and kingdoms! We don't abuse our power for our amusement!”

“Perhaps not you - you're far too straight-laced - but others?” Double Trouble snorted. “I've travelled a lot and I know better.”

“Are you really trying to give us a ‘you and I are the same’ speech?” Catra snorted.

Double Trouble narrowed their eyes - still Sam's eyes - at her for a moment, then grinned. “Worth a try. So, that's a no on the spaceship? I'm not working for free. I've got bills to pay.”

“More like bribes and fines, I bet,” Glimmer muttered.

“It's all the same. So… You want me to risk my life - my freedom, my body - for the Alliance. And if I do it, I'll be saving countless lives. That should be worth a pretty penny, in my opinion! Just think of all the money you'll be saving for repairs!”

Glimmer snorted. “You'll be impersonating an infamous System Lord. Don't tell me you wouldn't pay for that chance.”

“I never pay for things I can get for free, darling! It's bad business!”

And didn’t that sum up Double Trouble perfectly? Catra shook her head as the negotiations continued. It was all just a matter of money now.

Not that Double Trouble had fooled her, of course - Catra knew they would try to slip away on a ship or through the gate as soon as they saw their chance.

But Catra and Melog would not allow that.

*****

Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 10th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“The code checks out - it's the Supreme Commander,” the Clone at the terminal reported. “Opening the Iris.”

A moment later, the Iris retracted, and Jack O'Neill looked at the stabilised wormhole in the flagship's gate room.

“Sending the all-clear. Sent.”

“Hi, Jack!” Adora was the first through, followed by Glimmer and Bow. Adora's smile looked a bit forced, and Glimmer wasn't even hiding her scowl while Bow looked a bit concerned.

Then Carter arrived with a wide grin on her face, and Jack's eyes narrowed. He had never seen that expression on her face. It looked off - almost deranged.

And then another Carter arrived, with a familiar expression - lips pressed together, a slight front on her face as she tried to look professional and polite, yeah, that was Carter pissed off.

“Jack, this is Double Trouble. Double Trouble, General Jack O'Neill,” Adora confirmed Jack's suspicion.

“Ohh! You're the famous Jack!” The Doppelgänger gasped and clasped her hands over her - their - chest. “I’ve heard so much about you!”

Jack swallowed his reflexive ‘Only good things, I hope?’ response and looked at Carter.

“They've insisted on staying in this form for reasons unknown, sir,” Carter replied to his unsaid question.

“They like needling people,” Catra, who had brought up the rear with Melog, added.

“What? Little old me? Perish the thought!” Double Trouble’s laugh was much too loud for Carter and filled the entire room. “I just want to look my best when making a first impression, and Major Carter was the most attractive!”

“The only one who won't hurt you for copying them, you mean,” Catra said, flashing her fangs.

Judging by Carter's expression, she was reconsidering that stance. Well, Jack had told her before that there were times and places where professionalism was overrated - not lately, though.

Double Trouble laughed again. “As I said, she is the most attractive among you bunch - but she's also new; I've met the rest of you before. Consider this a demonstration of my skill.”

Jack snorted. “Consider me unimpressed, then. Looks aren't everything.”

Suddenly, the Doppelgänger’s entire stance and expression changed, all the exuberance vanishing in an instant as they straightened. “I concur, sir. For a perfect imitation, one has to copy not just the target's appearance, but everything about them - but most importantly, one has to understand them on a fundamental level. That requires thorough observation, preferably at different occasions so one can study how they react to various situations and stressors.”

Jack suppressed a shudder. That was… Carter. He couldn’t help but glance at the real Carter, just to check that she hadn't been switched with the copy. Nope, still there - and looking as unnerved as he felt.

He was almost glad when the fake Carter dropped the act again and looked around with open curiosity. “So… nice digs you have here. Or they would be if they didn't give me flashbacks to the war.”

Catra snorted again. “Spare us the theatrics. You never were on a Horde ship before.”

“How would you know?” Double Trouble shot back.

“You were hiding in the Enchanted Grotto until we exposed you,” Glimmer replied. “And we weren't missing a frigate after the war.”

Double Trouble laughed again in that un-Carter-like way of theirs. “Good point! But I did fight the very Clones who crew the ship. No hard feelings, I hope?”

“So did we,” Glimmer muttered.

The Clone in charge of the gateroom looked at them with a neutral expression. “The Supreme Commander has cleared you.”

“And that's all you need, right? Wow, you really haven’t changed, have you?” Double Trouble giggled - Carter never giggled - and then clapped her hands together. “So, let me take a look at the material you have on that ‘Ba'al’. If you don't let me visit the clone, I'll need every scrap of data you have on the target. Chop chop!”

Jack was reconsidering his stance on not allowing them access to the Fishtank. If they were sent to the Goa'uld holding area, they would be out of his hair for a while. Carter looked as if she was planning an accident for the Doppelgänger. Not that he couldn't understand her - if someone were wearing his face and body like that, he'd probably feel similarly.

Adora nodded. “Catra will lead you to the briefing room we prepared.”

“Oh, just give me directions! I'm sure I can find my w…ack!”

Catra had grabbed them by the neck, and Jack could see the tips of her claws just touching her skin. “You're not going anywhere alone.”

“It's as if you don't trust me! Aren't we supposed to work together?”

“We trust you - to be as annoying as possible,” Glimmer said.

“Now, let's go! Chop chop!” Catra all but marched Double Trouble out of the room, and the last Jack heard was a faint Wow! Are we really in space?” right before the doors closed.

He turned to look at Carter, who sighed. “Everything OK, Carter?”

She straightened at once. “Yes, sir. They're annoying, but I've worked with worse.”

Jack nodded. “Well, they're out of your hair for now. You can go back to dealing with Goa'uld networks,” he told her with a smile. “We'll handle them.”

“Yes, sir.” She nodded, but she didn't seem to be as relieved as he expected if the frown she aimed at the door was anything to go by.

*****

Adora had to admit that for all their *very* annoying attitude - she had no doubt that if anything happened to Double Trouble, almost everyone who had met them would cheer, even, or especially, Sam, and Jack might already be planning something - they were very good at what they did, and professional about it. Double Trouble had spent the last several hours reviewing every recording they had of Ba'al or his clones. And they had, finally, stopped using Sam's form and had started using Ba'al's preferred host's form.

Unfortunately, that hadn't helped with making them less annoying.

“Bow before your god! It is I, Ba'al, who has come to rule you! You shall rue the day you dared defy me! Resistance is useless! You cannot defeat a god! You may have defeated some of my supposed rivals, but they were weak - now you are facing Ba'al!”

They were obviously enjoying this, too.

“Looks like someone's read a few too many Fantastic Four comics. If this were public, Marvel would sue,” Jack commented.

“Oh, all those dictators sound somewhat alike. It's the common language of overblown egos,” Double Trouble said - with a smirk aimed at Catra.

“Then you don't even have to make any effort, just being yourself will be enough,” Catra shot back with a toothy, too toothy, smile.

“Oh, Kitty's got claws now!” Double Trouble chuckled, and, for a moment, Adora feared that they would push the issue and remind Catra of their shared past. And that wouldn't do anyone any good. But they shrugged and went on: “So, I've gotten through all you have on the man, snake, whatever.”

“Reptile would be an alternative.” Apparently, Sam could be a bit catty as well.

Adora was starting to wonder if hiring Double Trouble had been a good idea. Even Catra had said it was a stupid idea. But the alternatives were all… so bloody. Ba'al's organisation all but ensured that his forces wouldn't simply surrender should he be taken out. According to the analysts, even records of his defeat would not be enough to convince everyone of his commanders that he was genuinely defeated.

To be fair, the Alliance would have to do extensive scanning and testing to check if they caught the real Ba'al as well - and even so, one of his clones might be able to take over, perhaps without realising they were a clone.

Double Trouble grinned - and shifted into Sam's form. “Oh, are you mad I changed forms? Don't worry, your form is still my favourite. You’re the most attractive person among your bunch, after all. Right, General sir?” Their pose had changed as well; they were no longer sitting straight but draped over their chair in an almost lazy - or sensual - manner that more than a bit reminded Adora of Catra at her best - or worst, depending on the occasion.

If glares could kill, Double Trouble would be dead twice over. Maybe more.

Of course, that only encouraged them. “Oh, do you disagree, General? Or should I say Jack?”

Enough. “Stop it!” Adora spoke up. “We're here to prepare to deal with Ba'al. Riling up people doesn't help with that.”

“If you can't handle little old me, how do you think you can handle Ba'al? The guy's not dumb; he'll do much worse to rile you up so you will make mistakes.” Double Trouble shook their head with a wide grin. “Consider it training.”

“Ba'al wouldn't be so petty,” Catra cut in. “He would start killing or torturing prisoners to make us angry, not trying to start some relationship drama. This is no *cheap soap opera*.”

Double Trouble scowled in return. “There's nothing cheap about interpersonal drama! The tension! The emotions! You should know best how that can influence wars.”

Adora drew a sharp breath. They had gone there. She glanced at Catra.

Catra scoffed. “And if we were trying to work with Ba'al or trusted him, and he were like you, you might have a point. But we aren't and he isn't.” She leaned forward. “You should know best how devastating it can be when you suddenly discover in the middle of a battle that your allies don’t have your back.”

Double Trouble recoiled but recovered. “You're the Princess Alliance! We have a deal!”

“Yes, we do. So stop trying to make us break it or we will,” Glimmer said.

“Would you really be so petty as to abandon the best hope of saving all those people over some teasing?” Double Trouble looked around with a tight smile.

Catra shrugged pointedly. “If you can't control yourself you can't be trusted to pull this off anyway.”

Adora caught Double Trouble glancing at her and nodded.

Double Trouble's scowl deepened, but they slouched in their chair and crossed their arms over their chest. “You all need to loosen up!”

Adora took that as agreement to stop the petty needling and started the briefing.

*****

Deep Space, Ba'al's Realm, August 11th, 2000 (Earth Time)

As she had expected, Samantha Carter found the General doing the pre-flight check of the stealth shuttle the team would be taking for the infiltration mission. “Sir.”

“Carter!” He straightened from where he had been bent down to inspect the undercarriage. “You're early.”

She was aware of that - she had planned on it. “Just making sure everything is ready,” she lied. “This is an important mission.”

“Yes.” He nodded, then looked towards the hangar entrance. “I hope our latest volunteer won't be too difficult.”

Sam nodded. That they would be difficult was clear as day; the only question was how much trouble they would cause.

“And I hope they will pick another form. Having two of you around gets confusing,” he added after a moment, cocking his head to look at her.

She nodded a bit too firmly. “The last thing we need on a mission is confusion.”

“Right.” He nodded curtly.

For a moment, it looked like he was about to say something else, but he didn't.

Sam wasn't quite sure if she was relieved or disappointed. But they had an understanding. “I'll go set up, sir,” she said, and entered the shuttle. She needed to be prepared for their insertion - the target system had a lot more potential threats than any

system they had infiltrated before. Sure, none of the Death Gliders' sensors could detect an Alliance stealth shuttle - they had not detected the spy bots surrounding them either - but there was always blind luck.

And Sam wasn't in the habit of leaving things to luck. Not when she could help it.

*****

"So, that's the stealth shuttle!" Double Trouble had not changed forms, Sam noticed while she tried not to scowl. "Able to fly up right to an enemy flagship and dock with them being none the wiser! A ship after my taste!"

Sam pressed her lips together to avoid blurting out her first thought.

"You won't get one," Glimmer said it out loud. "They are reserved for Alliance special operations."

Sam expected the General to add: "And for my commute!", but he merely nodded with a tight-lipped expression.

"Aw! But they are made for me! Can they change shape as well? Or just transponders?" Double Trouble mock-whined in a way that Sam would never.

"We're going onto a dangerous mission," the General spoke up. "The danger of friendly fire is always present in such situations, and we can't afford any potential confusion. So, pick another shape to wear, Double Trouble. One we can't mistake for one of our own:"

"Really? You of all people think you would confuse me and Sam-Darling here?" Double Trouble laughed and stepped next to Sam before she could react. They tried to wrap an arm around Sam's shoulders, but she blocked them.

“See?” Double Trouble grinned and stepped in front of the General. “She's the grumpy, unapproachable one. I'm the friendly one!”

Sam imagined a little friendly fire right now. Using a taser. The General looked like he was imagining a little friendly fire with a flamethrower.

“Double Trouble!” Adora snapped. “Stop it!”

“Change into your usual form,” Catra said. “We wouldn't want to mistake you for someone else that Ba'al cloned. After all, his forces have met all of us before, and we don't know what he's been up to.”

Double Trouble narrowed her eyes and scowled - Sam made a note to check if she ever looked like that - before snorting. “And you'd shoot first and ask questions later, huh?”

Catra shrugged and bared her teeth in a wide grin. “With a zat, we can just stun people and wake them up later.”

“It might be less trouble for the team if we would stun the shapeshifter before departure and wake them up once we have secured Ba'al, Supreme Commander. I could carry them without much trouble,” Teal'c commented with such a perfectly bland expression, Sam would not have realised he wasn't serious, at least not entirely so, if she hadn't known him as well as she did.

“What?” Double Trouble gasped at him, then looked at the others.

Adora blinked, Catra’s grin grew even wider - Sam didn't have to look at Melog to confirm she was amused - and Glimmer looked smug. Even Bow seemed to struggle not to smile.

Sam caught herself grinning as well.

Double Trouble muttered a curse under their breath and shifted into their lizard-like form. “I wonder how you think you can win

this war when you can't even handle a little chaos in your schedule.”

“Wouldn't you like to know?” the General asked with a satisfied grin as everyone boarded the shuttle.

*****

The Election Campaign Part 4

PB-1763 System, Ba'al's Realm, August 11th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"We've entered the target system and switched to passive sensors."

Catra nodded at Jack's announcement and checked their position on the holoprojection. They were flying on a slightly curved route that would take them around some of the known concentrations of enemy craft and avoid flying too close to the staging points of Ba'al's fleet in the system - at least on the approach; couldn't do anything about having to close in with them when they had to land on the planet.

"Do we have to whisper? Your stealth system is so good, we could hitch a ride on the next enemy ship, couldn't we?"

And Double Trouble was still fishing for information. So, they must have heard something about Alliance stealth ships. Probably some sailor with loose lips - another reason not to let Double Trouble out of their sight on this mission; they already knew far too much about the Alliance.

"It's traditional not to yell when you're sneaking," Jack said.

"Traditional? I thought Earth was all about efficiency!"

"We're traditionally efficient," he shot back.

"I'm suddenly not so confident that this will work," Double Trouble went on - but in a joking tone.

Catra shrugged. "The sensors aren't a problem out here - the real issue is to get down on the planet without the plasma from re-entry marking our position for every ship with a line of sight to us."

“What?” Double Trouble didn’t sound amused any more. “I was told this is a routine mission for you!”

“We routinely risk our lives on such missions, yes,” Glimmer commented. Catra didn’t have to turn her head to know she was grinning.

“We have done this before,” Bow, ever the spoilsport, cut in. “Though usually, we didn’t have to deal with quite so many ships guarding the planet.”

“Really? I’m not an expert - though I could be, in an instant!”

“Don’t copy Sam or anyone else here!” Adora interrupted them.

Double Trouble rolled her eyes. “Anyway, how can you avoid being detected when they have ships covering the entire planet?”

“By being very sneaky,” Jack replied. “We’ve got a plan.”

“Yes! With a very good chance to work and not kill us all!” Entrapta chimed in, beaming at them. “We got it ready in time for this mission!”

Catra suppressed a wince. Entrapta was as honest as ever, but ‘a very good chance to work and not kill us all’ were not the kind of odds Catra liked.

That Double Trouble liked them even less helped keep her grin on her face, of course. Anything to rile up them.

“Now be quiet! We’re closing in on the first Death Glider network.”

“I thought they couldn’t hear us in space.”

“They can’t. But I can, and I need to focus on flying this ship,” Jack said.

“Yes,” Sha’re, the co-pilot added. “This requires our concentration.”

Catra could tell how much it cost Double Trouble - their expressions were almost comically clear - but they did fall silent while the Stealth Shuttle continued its approach.

*****

PB-1763 Orbit, PB-1763 System, Ba'al's Realm, August 11th, 2000 (Earth Time)

"That's your plan? Dropping us from orbit? In *caskets*?"

Catra smirked at Double Trouble's outburst.

"Those aren't caskets." Entrapta shook her head. "Those are drop pods - stealth drop pods. With a bot navigation system. They are small enough and manoeuvrable enough so they can make atmospheric re-entry without creating a bigger thermic trace than a bunch of micrometeorites. So! Unless Ba'al's sensor net is calibrated for tracking micrometeorites, we should be perfectly fine in them! And even if something goes wrong, they wouldn't be caskets!" She frowned. "Mostly because they would be destroyed with the passenger, of course. Although that could be called a sort of cremation if it happens in the higher atmosphere, and they do use caskets for that - even though it's such a waste, burning perfectly fine wood! - so… They could be caskets, I guess."

"You guess?"

"Get into your pod, Double Trouble," Adora spoke up.

"We can always zat them and stuff them into the pod to collect them on the ground," Glimmer added.

"That's… That wasn't the deal!"

"It was. You just didn't care about the details," Catra said.

"Is this your revenge for me teaching you a much-needed lesson?"

Catra shook her head. “This is just for being an asshole.”

Double Trouble was about to respond, but Sam stepped in front of her. “We’re on a timer. Everyone needs to get in their pods.”

Catra checked her helmet seal - not that her suit would help her if the pod malfunctioned during re-entry, but they were going into space - and climbed into her pod. The lid closed with a slight hissing sound, and the inside lit up with a holographic projection that let her see the outside.

“Drop Pod One, ready.”

“Drop Pod Three, ready.”

“Drop Pod Five, ready.”

“Drop Pod Four, ready.”

“Drop Pod Seven, ready.”

“Drop Pod Six, ready.”

Catra listened to the bot voices reporting from the different pods, counting off.

“All pods ready.”

“Release!” Sha’re, now the pilot in charge, ordered.

Then the bottom seemed to fall out from underneath Catra, and her tail swung wildly as she instinctively tried to stabilise her fall before the pod’s inertial compensators kicked in, and she felt gravity again.

Her stomach still protested since, according to her eyes, she was falling forward - head first - toward the planet.

Then she hit the atmosphere, and everything lit up.

*****

Jack O'Neill clenched his teeth as the picture projected on the 'lid' of his drop pod switched to a good attempt at how the sun must look inside, and the entire pod started to shake almost violently. He had gone through many re-entries before, but those had been with his shuttle - protected by armour, shielding and inertial compensators that turned the process into a smooth ride with a nice light show.

Strapped into a small pod, feeling every vibration even with the rudimentary inertial compensators installed, and hoping that Carter, Entrapta and Bow hadn't missed a small but fatal mistake when they had thrown those things together was a very different experience. Of course, he trusted Carter with his life without hesitation, but… it was a bit easier to trust her with his life when he wasn't currently surrounded by plasma and hoping no Death Glider pilot decided to use the apparent micrometeor for a spontaneous target practice session. Damn, he wished this wouldn't take so long - even if the risk of getting detected was higher the faster they were, waiting inside this pod - which the soldiers were going to call 'coffins', Jack knew - was almost torture.

Finally, the picture changed again, now showing the planet below and space above them - they were through the worst part. His holographic display also showed that they hadn't lost any pod on the way - all of them lit up green, and he let out a relieved breath.

Then the turbulences started, and he cursed again. He had flown through turbulences before, and he knew better than most that even modern planes could be wrecked by them. This falling coffin had advanced technology, but just enough to make taking it down to the ground not outright suicide.

His pod started to veer and roll around - he saw it on the display with the artificial horizon, but the way he was pulled into the harness holding him safe would have been clue enough. It was a pilot's worst nightmare - all his instincts were screaming that he was in a flat spin and he was about to crash if he didn't do something.

“Trust Carter; she said that this was normal and planned for,” he muttered to himself through clenched teeth as the ground grew closer and closer. “This thing is on autopilot.” Had to be - you couldn’t really teach ground forces to steer what was a one-way miniature spaceship. Not without turning them into pilots.

But as the pod kept falling, it kept spinning. Was it defective? No! Jack gasped when he realised that the pod was adjusting their course towards the rally spot. And it was slowing down! If only it stopped spinning…

It did stop spinning about a second before it hit the ground, straightening and rightening itself just in time to plant its bottom into the ground - though not deep enough to keep standing; Jack sighed when the pod toppled over, rolling as it fell so it would land on its back.

“Climbing out of a coffin isn’t how you’re supposed to invade a planet,” he muttered as he hit the quick release of his harness and opened the lid. “Then again, you also aren’t supposed to jump out of a perfectly working plane, but here we are.”

He looked around, rifle ready. Half a dozen pods had landed almost on top of him, all but one - Drop Pod Two - opening. A few were a bit further away.

Catra slid out of hers, crouching on all fours as she looked around, quickly joined by Melog.

Adora all but jumped out, sword out and in full She-Ra regalia.

Glimmer appeared in a cloud of sparkles, grinning wildly. “Hah! This world didn’t have a Stargate, so the First Ones couldn’t steal its magic!”

Oh. That was good since it meant Glimmer could teleport. But it was also bad since it meant Adora didn’t have the ‘unleash the world’s magic and turn all enemies into turnips’ ace up her sleeve. Still, good to have confirmation - with the way some snakes were

moving Stargates around, and the data banks being less than reliable, they hadn't been sure.

And there came Carter and Entrapta! Safe and sound! Jack smiled.

"See? The spins served to slow down our fall as planned! And it was a nice ride, too!" Entrapta beamed.

Jack stopped smiling. So, that had been deliberate.

Carter must have caught his mood since she said: "The spinning also serves to throw off an enemy gunner's aim, should they detect the pods, sir."

Yeah, and it probably saved some power, too - but Jack had a feeling they had picked that system because Entrapta thought it was fun.

Well, there would be time enough to talk about briefing your test subjects more thoroughly even if time was precious once they were done here. He looked around. Everyone was accounted for except the still closed pod.

"They're pounding against the lid. I think we need to let them out now," Catra said.

"Oh, yes!" Entrpata nodded and pointed her multitool at it.

A moment later, the lid opened, and they heard Double Trouble's voice: "...open, you piece of crap! I'm not going to end up as a snake egg incubator because of… Oh."

"Seems like your pod had a malfunction," Jack told them. "Carter, make a note to look into that afterwards. We can't have our troops be caught in their coffins."

"Yes, sir!"

“Really?” Double Trouble narrowed their eyes at him. “That’s your story?”

Jack nodded. That was his story, and he would be sticking to it. “Alright, grab the gear from the pods, then hit the self-destruct and let’s be on our way. We’ve got a way to hike before we reach our objective.”

“We’re going to *walk*?” Double trouble gasped as if they hadn’t known that from the briefing.

Jack ignored them and grabbed his rucksack from his pod, then started the process that would turn the pod into dust in a process that Carter said totally wasn’t burning it to ashes… He sighed. There really was no way the troops wouldn’t be making coffin and ashes to ashes, dust to dust jokes once they got their hands on the production models.

*****

Wilderness, PB-1763, Ba'al's Realm, August 11th, 2000 (Earth Time)

“This is undignified!”

Adora ignored Double Trouble's complaints. If they didn't want to be carried ‘like a bag of potatoes’, they should have kept walking.

“You're literally carried by a princess, and you think it's undignified?” Glimmer sounded amused.

“It is! This isn't a princess carry - she's slung me over her shoulder!”

Well, Adora needed at least one hand free if they were attacked, and she already had a pack with a spy bot in it on her back, so that left her shoulders.

“Adora could always just drag you.” Catra, on the other hand, wasn't amused, as her snidish tone illustrated whenever she

wasn't scouting ahead.

But that couldn't be helped - they had to cover quite the distance, and if Double Trouble was being dramatic - their feet were never in danger of 'literally falling off' - then carrying them was the obvious solution. It kept the group on schedule and also made it harder for Double Trouble to run off.

Running off on a planet held by Ba'al, and which would soon be facing a massive attack by the Alliance forces if this mission failed, wouldn't be very smart, but Double Trouble had done more stupid things - they weren't as smart as they claimed to be, in Adora's opinion. Then again, few people who claimed they were smart were that smart, in her experience.

They were moving through a dense forest - they had adapted their planned route as they approached the planet since they had gotten their best scan of the surface - and making decent time. They would be making better time if they were walking through more open terrain, but that would expose them, and Ba'al had too many Death Gliders up in the airspace for that. Even if many of those were test flights and not patrols, the risk was still too high.

"Hey! Watch where you walk - you almost smashed my face into the trunk here!"

Adora rolled her eyes. She hadn't even come close!

"It's a pity she didn't succeed!" Catra mumbled as she passed them.

"Hey!"

"I wish we'd have the time to build a drop pod for Emily," Entrapta said behind her. "And a stealth module for her, or, at least, a better shielding for her engines so she can better hide from sensors. Then she could carry us through this!"

Adora doubted that - the forest was a bit too dense for a bot the size of Emily to walk through without having to literally cut a path

for herself; they had seen that often enough in the war against the Horde, where they had used that to track and ambush the bot forces. And unlike in the Whispering Woods, this forest wouldn't grow over such tracks in a day or two.

Well, she hoped they wouldn't.

“I still don't know why I couldn't have waited back in a safe and comfortable spot for you to reach the palace and then have Glimmer fetch me by teleport!” Double Trouble was pouting behind Adora's back; she didn't have to look over her shoulder to know that.

“Because you'd have been gone the moment we were out of sight,” Glimmer replied.

“Don't you trust me?”

“No.”

“You could have left someone else with me. Like Daniel - he doesn't look that happy to walk all over this planet himself! I'd change into his wife's form so he doesn't have to worry too much about her being left alone in orbit in a single shuttle!”

Adora clenched her teeth. That was a low blow, even if Double Trouble didn't know about Daniel and Sha're's tragic past.

“Jack?”

“Yes, Daniel?”

“Remember what I said about treating our latest ally with more respect?”

“Yes?”

“I take it back!”

“No one here has a sense of humour! Or a taste for the performing arts!”

“We do. That's why we know how bad you are,” Glimmer shot back.

“Well, we don't actually know - we’ve never seen them on stage,” Entrapta commented while her hair tendrils wrapped around a tree branch and lifted her over a tangle of thick roots. “I think, at least - it's not as if we'd be able to tell, would we?”

“Oh, I am sure you have seen me perform in one of my many forms. I captured the hearts of audiences all over Etheria! Some of the best actresses can thank me for their fame!”

“You just made that up when Entrapta gave you the idea,” Glimmer said with a scoff.

“How would you be able to tell?” Adora heard and felt Double Trouble chuckle. “In the future, you won't ever be sure if that great performance was me or someone else!”

That was… well, a worrying possibility. Or would be if not for Melog, Adora thought.

“Stop it with the inane drivel!” Catra hissed as she dropped to the ground from the tree ahead of them. “I've found traces of an old campsite ahead.”

Oh. They shouldn't be near the outer perimeter of Ba'al's palace yet. Did he have patrols range that far? On foot?

“Let's take a look,” Jack said in a lower voice than before.

Catra led them through the woods, past a really dense patch of underbrush - a former clearing about to be grown over if Adora remembered Bow's comments about the woods correctly - and to a huge tree.

And she was correct - there were the remains of a fireplace there and other traces of a camp.

Bow knelt down and ran a finger along a dent in the ground, then looked at the ashes scattered over the ground. “About a few days old, I think. Any longer, and it would have been gone already.”

“If we're stopping here, then you can let me down now, you know?”

Adora ignored them again and looked around. If it had only been a few days, then whoever had done this might still be in the area…

*****

“What do you make of it?” the General asked. “Some long-range patrol? Or fugitives?”

“Probably fugitives,” Bow replied. “The campsite is not ideal - there are better spots nearby - but it's very well hidden from aerial observation. A patrol wouldn't have had any need to hide and would have picked a better spot for a camp.”

Samantha Carter agreed with the logic, though she had to take Bow's words for the reasons - she wasn't enough of an expert on such things to tell.

“If there are fugitives, then there will be hunters,” Catra said. “The question is, will they use ground forces to hunt down fugitives - or will they stick to Death Gliders?”

“They have a ton of Death Gliders. Ba'al might think bombing fugitives is good training.” The General shrugged. “But they seem to know how to hide.”

Or they were dead already, Sam thought. The distance to the palace - the closest inhabited area from here - meant they would have managed to reach this spot if they had fled at dusk and walked as quickly as Sam and her friends were going. If this was

a few days old, then Ba'al's forces would have had enough time to hunt them down.

Daniel was going through the ashes. “There's nothing here - no trash, no broken tool, no leftovers from anything they might have crafted or repaired. A nomadic culture setting up a camp would likely perform such activities and leave corresponding traces.”

“And what does that mean in non-Archaeologist, Daniel?”

“It means I don't think this was a camp set by indigenous travellers. It would fit a group of fugitives who didn't have the opportunity to make or repair tools,” Daniel replied.

“You mean they weren't prepared?” Glimmer asked.

“That is difficult to say. They could have no need yet to repair or craft anything since they set out well-prepared,” Daniel said. “Or they had to flee in a hurry and couldn't take anything with them that would require repairs.”

“Oh! We can give them what they need - or make it for them!” Entrapta chimed in.

Sam glanced at Adora and saw she was wincing.

“We can't spend the time tracking down a group of fugitives trying to hide,” Adora said. “The best thing we can do to help them is to take out Ba'al and take over the planet.”

“I wouldn't mind a detour,” Double Trouble, still slung over Adora's shoulder, spoke up. “This is not very comfortable. Your shoulders are very bony.”

Sam couldn’t care less about the shapeshifter's discomfort.

“Shift to a more padded form, then,” Glimmer told them.

A moment later, Double Trouble had shifted into a double of Glimmer. “You're right; this helps. You must have spoken from

experience.”

To Sam's surprise, Glimmer didn’t seem annoyed but snorted, apparently amused. “Let's go now. The sooner we reach Ba'al's palace, the sooner we can stop whatever suffering the people here endure.”

“Yeah,” the General agreed.

Adora still looked guilty but nodded as well.

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Near Ba'al's Palace, PB-1763, Ba'al's Realm, August 12th, 2000 (Earth Time)

It had taken them several hours, but shortly after midnight, they had reached their target - or, at least, the vicinity of their target. Usually, a Goa'uld base would be in the middle of a flat, wide area, cleared to remove all cover and concealment. Ba'al's palace differed. The forest had been cleared, the trees cut down, in the entire area, but instead of a featureless plain where hiding would be impossible without advanced technology - and difficult even with such technology, given its limitations - it was surrounded by fields and irrigation canals fed from a lake.

Between the lake and a village - a small town, actually - that housed the slaves working the fields lay the palace. Hidden in the underbrush at the tree line at the outward edge of the fields, Samantha Carter studied the buildings through her binoculars, using the night vision mode, although enhanced to show true colours.

“Interesting,” Daniel commented in a low voice. “I would have expected less Egyptian architecture given Ba'al's history, more Phoenician, probably Punic, but the palace shows few such influences - a few ornaments, possibly furniture, but the general layout and building style is almost exclusively Egyptian. This may signal Ba'al's intention to take over as Ra's successor, but why would he go that far on a secret world?”

“He probably doesn't intend to keep it secret once he is the new Emperor,” the General replied.

“Oh. Right. That would be possible. Still, it could also indicate a true cultural shift on Ba'al's side. Perhaps it’s an attempt to improve his reputation and downplay his past actions so the other System Lords will more likely accept his rule?”

Sam doubted that it would work, genuine or not - in her opinion, the only thing that would make the System Lords accept an emperor was naked strength and power. And even then, they would secretly plot to topple them as soon as they thought they could get away with it. Still, it would be like Ba'al to do something like that in order to gain a small advantage. And, of course, the advantage might not be so small when it concerned the slaves and Jaffa, who would have suffered the most from his past crimes.

Sam hoped it wouldn't ultimately matter - they were here to end Ba'al's reign, after all. And those irrigation canals provided a great opportunity to sneak to the palace - and likely into it, since the palace probably drew water from the lake as well.

She looked the palace over again. Several defensive gun emplacements lined the walls. Dual-purpose, able to engage aerial threats as well as ground targets - and three covered the village. Patrols on the walls and at the base of the walls, probably on both sides of them, and in the fields. Those were pretty standard defences. Ba'al almost assuredly had some nastier surprises hidden in the palace and a few escape routes prepared, but Sam was confident they could deal with that; between Entrapta, Bow and herself, and their experience with Ba'al's systems, they should be able to take over the security systems and sensors easily enough.

“Alright. It looks like we've got a window of opportunity to reach the walls through the canal there as soon as that patrol has passed us,” Adora said in a low voice over the communicator. “Be ready.”

Sam was ready.

*****

Ba'al's Palace, PB-1763, Ba'al's Realm, August 12th, 2000 (Earth Time)

Passing underwater through the irrigation canals to the palace walls had been slightly uncomfortable but easily handled. The new uniforms and their sealed helmet option helped a lot. If her fur had gotten all wet… Catra shuddered at the thought. There had been a lot of gunk in the murky water, and she didn't give a damn whether that stuff would be good fertiliser for the fields or not, and that the wastewater from the palace had to go somewhere, as Daniel and Sam had explained - they didn't have fur all over their body that would take ages to clean if that filth got on it.

But now they had to enter the palace proper, and that meant diving deeper into the lake here - according to Entrapta and Sam's scans, the pipe that led into the palace grounds was pretty far down there. Something about varying levels of water or whatever. But unlike the spot where the palace's wastewater line fed into the main canal, this spot wasn't guarded by a squad of Jaffa.

It still meant that they had to dive a bit too deep for her taste. Fortunately, the uniforms were rated for space, so they didn't have to worry about pressure effects and things. They only had to deal with security systems, sensors and traps.

"Alright, the sensors covering the lake are currently blind to us," Entrapta reported over the communicator.

"Let's dive and rally at the target," Adora ordered.

Catra was first into the water. No 'cats and water' jokes today for her. She didn't jump, of course - that would have caused a splash guards could hear - but slid into the water and then dived down, the HUD in her helmet showing her where she needed to go. If they had had such a thing in the Horde, a number of exercises

and operations would have gone differently. Well, some of the officers would have still managed to get lost, she was sure of that.

Forcing the stupid stray thoughts away, she pressed on, quickly reaching the large pipe that took water from the lake into the palace. There was a massive grate on it, but that wouldn't stop her. Once the others caught up - she made sure that Double Trouble hadn't gotten ‘lost’ on the way - and Sam checked that the sensors were off, Catra quickly sliced through the metal, and Adora pulled the grate away.

Entrapta sent the spy bot they had brought along ahead, and Catra closely followed its track on her HUD as it entered the pipe. Between the data data from the hacked security system and the stealthed bot, she got a decent picture of the pipe's interior as she looked for traps and other obstacles. It would be just like Ba'al to have some undocumented surprises in such places to catch those who thought that they just had to deal with the computers to get in. Though any trap would have to operate under some limitations, what with the need to let water in, so the trigger couldn't be too simple, and that meant sensors as well.

Ah! She grinned inside her helmet when she spotted a sensor on the feed from the bot that wasn't already marked by the HUD. “There's a trap ahead,” she said.

“Got it!” Entrapta's voice answered. “Good bot! Now let's see what… Oh! That's a shaped charge, aimed down the pipe - the pressure probably would… no, the pipe's reinforced, so it wouldn't burst but funnel the pressure wave forward. Quite nasty.”

Catra kept smiling even though she couldn't help imagining what would happen to anyone inside the pipe if the trap was triggered. They'd be pulped.

But her friends were already working on it, directing the bot to close in, and then started to disarm it - after the group had cleared the pipe entrance. Just in case.

But the charge didn't go off, and the bot moved on. They detected another trap, a stunning device built into the pipe where it bent to head straight up, but that was easily dealt with by hacking its sensor, and after cutting through a few more grates and filters, the bot reached the main water reservoir of the palace and surfaced in it.

“Jackpot,” Jack muttered as the feeds showed rails lining the basin and ladders leading up.

“Multiple sensors that track the water quality,” Sam reported. “We have to hack them so they won't report the effects of the bot cutting through the filters.”

More delays - but necessary ones. Waiting underwater was getting a bit stressful. Fortunately, it didn't take too long until Sam announced that it was safe now, and Catra was the first into the pipe.

She quickly swam forward, resisting the urge to use her claws to pull herself along the pipe even if it would have been a bit faster, then up once she reached the bend.

Then she hit the surface inside the reservoir and looked around. No guards, no obvious traps.

They had it made inside the palace. Now came the fun part.

*****

Sneaking around in a snake palace never got old! Jack O’Neill bared his teeth in a grin while he peered around the corner ahead - he might be covered by Melog’s illusion, but better safe than sorry; nothing was perfect. Certainly not magic.

But the corridor ahead was clear. No surprise there - they were just above the cistern, and it was pretty damp here; Ba’al’s contractors must have pulled a fast one on him - according to Carter and Entrapta’s scans, the entire level here was useless for

pretty much anything that couldn't handle lots of humidity. No provisions, delicate electronics or archives would survive here.

Of course, Ba'al being Ba'al, he still found a use for it - the cold humidity was perfect for some good old-fashioned dungeon, as long as you don't mind that your prisoners died from pneumonia or inhaling poisonous mould or whatever. And Jack hadn't yet met a snake who would mind that. In fact, knowing Ba'al, he might have micro-managed construction to ensure he got mouldy cells in his dungeon…

Of course, anyone with a symbiont wouldn't die from a bit of mould and cold. And the prisoner they had detected with their scans had a symbiont inside them. The only question was whether they were a Jaffa or a snake.

As he moved down the corridor, to the cell tracts projected on his HUD, Jack hoped they were a Jaffa; you couldn't trust the snakes.

He reached the door barring the way into the dungeon proper and stepped to the side, letting his carbine drop, caught by the sling, to draw his zat while Carter and Bow dealt with the lock. There shouldn't be any guards inside. Entrapta was monitoring the hacked security system and hadn't spotted anyone behind the door who wasn't in a cell. And the magic scanner hadn't detected any symbionts outside the one in a cell, either.

But it wouldn't hurt to be ready to stun someone before they could raise the alarm.

"Oh! That's interesting…" Entrapta muttered.

He glanced at her, then at Carter. Carter would be able to tell if whatever Entrapta was talking about was important enough to share with the class, right?

"Entrapta?" Carter asked.

Or not.

“Oh, it’s just the camera layout. It’s quite complex - you know that already - but there are some blind spots that are cleverly hidden!”

Oh? “Maybe Ba’al’s IT guy isn’t as good as he should be,” Jack said.

“No, no, that seems deliberate - there’s a subroutine that alters the coverage angle without reporting it to the controls. Hm…”

“So, someone infiltrated this system before us? I guess the Tok’ra will feel even more embarrassed,” Jack commented. Would serve them right, actually.

“But who could have done this? A rival? Sokar, maybe? Or a third faction we don’t know yet?” Daniel speculated.

“Or someone planning a coup,” Catra said.

“Well, I’m looking into this!” Entrapta announced - her face was almost completely hidden behind all the displays in her helmet, Jack noted. It didn’t seem like she could see through it.

But before he could say anything, Bow spoke up. “Finally! That was harder than we expected! But we managed it!”

It has taken longer than I expected, Jack thought as he turned around and aimed his zat at the door. A moment later, it slid to the side, revealing an empty room - empty of people, that was. There were lots of torture devices. Some of them wouldn’t have looked out of place in a fantasy movie, and some looked like someone misused a dentist’s tools.

“Guess our pal Ba’al is a torture connoisseur. No one-size-fits-all torture device for him; he wants variety and all the classics,” Jack joked and managed not to wince at what he recognised as a flensing knife thanks to one of Daniel’s bloodier lectures.

“Oh. You think that’s Ba’al’s personal torture chamber?” Double Trouble bent over a rack. “How interesting!”

They sounded far too happy about this.

“This is so inspiring!” they went on.

Jack wasn’t the only one narrowing his eyes at them, and Double Trouble looked annoyed when they noticed. “To better play his role, of course! This gives crucial insight into his character! Really, what do you think I meant?”

“That you like to torment people,” Catra replied.

“Really! How long will you carry a grudge? It was good for you!”

“I can think of a few things that would be good for you too.” Catra flashed her fangs.

“According to the security records, there is currently no cell occupied, sir,” Carter interrupted the brewing clash from the closest console. “Our scans confirm that one is occupied, though.”

“But the cell’s not under surveillance,” Bow added.

“And no guards are supposed to be here.”

“And there are no guards. So… this is either the planet’s most harmless prisoners… or someone no one is supposed to know about,” Catra said.

Adora nodded. “Let’s find out.”

Jack went in first, just in case. Adoa could fix him if anything happened. But he couldn’t fix her if Ba’al had cooked up something nasty enough to harm She-Ra.

He reached the cell marked on his HUD easily. There was no window in the door to peer inside either. More sloppy design?

Carter and Bow went to work on the lock of the door while the rest secured the area. Once again, it took them longer than

expected - Carter seemed both annoyed and impressed, Jack noted.

But they managed to unlock the cell. Jack aimed his zat with one hand and opened the door with the other, revealing…

… Ba’al?

*****

“Colonel O'Neill… and She-Ra, Princess of Power, Protector of Etheria. I have to say that it is a surprise to see you two together, but I really should have seen this. The clues were all there.”

Adora stared at the smirking man. Ba'al? In his own prison cell? That made no…

Catra's laugh interrupted her thoughts. “So, are you the original Ba'al who fell victim to a coup or a clone who failed to coup the original?”

Ah! That would explain it - of course, Catra would think of this, given her past.

Ba'al, who was wearing pretty plain clothes, not a glimpse of jewellery visible, shrugged. “Does it matter? What matters is that I am an enemy of your enemy, as my current circumstances clearly prove.” He smiled at them, his eyes seeking out Adora's. “We are natural allies.”

“If you say: ‘join me, and together we can rule the galaxy’, I'll have to shoot you,” Jack said.

“Indeed.” Teal'c was glaring at the Goa'uld.

Ba'al, still smirking, tilted his head slightly as he looked at Jack. “I would not make such an offer, Colonel O'Neill, since you aren't a fool, and neither am I.”

“It's General these days,” Jack replied. “Just for the record. Wouldn't want to confuse people.”

Right. This Ba'al knew about She-Ra, which meant he had had access to the intel the Commander must have shared with Ba'al back in May this year. So, his imprisonment would have been a relatively recent event.

“General O'Neill.” Ba'al nodded with what looked like genuine respect, even if he was still smirking. “Of course, your people would promote you, given your many victories over the Goa'uld.”

Jack shrugged. “I just do what is needed. You know, pest control.”

Ba'al nodded again and looked at Adora. “But none of those victories were as impressive as defeating Horde Prime and taking his realm for yourself.”

That… wasn't exactly what had happened. Not like that. And shouldn't he know that? He had recruited the Commander and his fleet, after all. Adora narrowed her eyes. Was he fishing for information?

“Flattery won't get you anything,” Catra spoke up.

“My experience would contradict that,” Ba'al said.

“Of course it would - your people always flattered you, didn't they?” Glimmer cut in. “And the only peers you met were other System Lords - or yourself.”

“You make a good point, Miss…? Or should that be Princess?”

That was a good guess. But no one had ever called Ba'al stupid.

“It's Queen these days,” Glimmer said.

“Ah.” Ba'al looked from her to Adora and back before smirking at Jack. “You keep interesting company, General. It seems you've become a bit more tolerant of other forms of government. Unless

this is merely a temporary alliance and you intend to settle your ideological differences once you have taken care of your common enemies.”

“We’re not like you!” Glimer spat.

“So it may seem.” Ba'al laughed. “But trust me on this - you won't have the measure of someone until and unless they are in a position to betray you and either do it or don't.”

Was that a subtle claim that he was the original? Well, every clone thought they were the real Ba'al, didn't they?

“Well, we found out who's in this cell, and I think you'll keep. We can continue this talk once we've stopped kicking your other version's ass,” Jack said.

“I wouldn't be so hasty, General,” Ba'al said - a bit too quickly for his confident tone. “You've managed to sneak into my palace, but you are undoubtedly aware of how many forces I have amassed here - and how their weapons have been upgraded. My help would allow you to take this system without suffering huge casualties. Or causing them,” he added with a smile while looking straight at Adora. “I think you are familiar with my standing orders for my forces - this will be a bloodbath even if you had overwhelming numbers, and the fact that you are currently here, in a covert and likely desperate attempt to decapitate my forces, tells me that you would prefer to avoid an all-out battle. I can help you there - and all I am asking for is a temporary alliance where you'd be holding all the cards.”

He was good, Adora had to admit. Even a bit charming. But he was right - they were holding all the cards. And he was Ba'al.

She turned to Double Trouble. “Do you think that's enough?”

They smiled and nodded - and turned into Ba'al.

The expression on Ba'al's face when he saw this almost made Adora laugh out loud.

Jack and Catra didn't show such restraint.

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